

Plato

Complete Works

translated by David Horan

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Alcibiades I

ΑΛΚΙΒΙΑΔΗΣ Ι

Plato

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

ALCIBIADES a famous and notorious politician and general

scene: somewhere in Athens, unspecified

103a

Socrates: Son of Clinias, I think you are amazed that, being your first lover, I alone have not departed now that the others have gone, and although the others conversed with you in droves, I, in contrast, have not addressed you for so many years. The cause of this was nothing human. No, it was a spiritual opposition, and later you will learn about its power. But now, since it is no longer opposing me, I have come to you in this way and I have good hopes that it will not oppose me again in future. In the meantime, I have, in a sense, been observing you and noticing how you related to those lovers, for despite being numerous and high-minded there is not one of them who has not fled, outdone by your superiority. But I wish to explain the reason for your exalted notions. You claim not to need a single other person for any purpose, for you have great qualities so that you lack nothing, beginning with the body and ending with the soul. Of course you believe, firstly, that you are supreme in beauty and greatness and it is plain for all to see that you are not lying. What is more, you belong to the most powerful family in your own city which is the greatest in Greece, and within that city you have, through your father, numerous excellent friends and kindred who would serve your every need; and those on your mother's side are in no way inferior or less numerous. But you think you possess a greater power than all of those I have mentioned, in the person of Pericles¹, the son of Xanthippos, whom your father left as guardian of yourself and your brother, a man who may act as he pleases, not only in this city, but throughout all Greece and among the many great tribes of non-Greeks. I shall also mention your wealth, but it seems to me

that you are much less proud of that. On account of all these factors you are boastful, and you have prevailed over your lovers while they, in their inferiority, have been dominated. None of this has escaped your notice. And so I know quite well that you are wondering what exactly I have in mind when I do not give up the love, and what sort of hope I am retaining when I remain after the others have gone.

104d

Alcibiades: But Socrates, you probably do not know that you are just a little ahead of me. For I already intended going to you to ask you these very questions: what exactly do you want and what hope do you entertain in pestering me, always anxious to be present wherever I might be? Yes, I really do wonder what precisely your objective is and I would like you to tell me.

Socrates: Then it is likely that you will listen to me eagerly since, as you say, you wish to know what I have in mind. And I presume I am speaking to someone who will stay and listen.

Alcibiades: Yes, certainly, just speak.

104e

Socrates: Be careful though, for it would be no surprise if I were to prove just as reluctant to stop speaking as I was to start.

Alcibiades: Excellent man, speak. I shall listen!

105a

Socrates: I must speak, then. Now, although it is difficult for a lover to approach a man who does not give way to lovers, I must nevertheless dare to speak my mind. Indeed Alcibiades, if I had seen you being delighted with what I have been describing just now and believing that you must live your life in their possession, I would have given up the love long ago, or so I convince myself anyway. But now I shall point out to you different notions of yours, and from this you will realise that you have been constantly on my mind. For I believe that if some

god were to say, “Alcibiades, would you prefer to live on, possessing what you now possess, or die on the spot if you were going to be unable to acquire more?” I think you would choose to die. And I shall tell you the very hope for which you are now living. You think that if you appear before the Athenian people, something which will happen in just a few days, you will stand before them and prove to the Athenians that you are worthy of more honour than Pericles, or anyone who has ever been born, and once you prove this you will be supremely powerful in the city, and if you are the greatest man here you will be greatest among the Greeks, and not only among the Greeks, but among the non-Greeks who live on the same continent as us. And if this same god were to go on and say that you must exercise power in Europe, but will not be allowed to go across into Asia or interfere in the affairs of her people, I do not think you would wish to live under those strictures either, if you could not also, in some sense, fill the whole world with your name and your power. And I think that apart from Cyrus and Xerxes², you believe that no one worthy of note has been born. Now, I know very well that this is the hope you entertain. I am not guessing. Therefore, since you realise that I am speaking the truth, perhaps you might say, “Well now, Socrates, what has this to do with the explanation you promised as to why you will not leave me?” So I shall tell you, dear son of Clinias and Deinomache, for without me it is impossible to bring all these plans of yours to completion, such power do I believe I have over you and your affairs. Yes, I think that is why the god would not allow me to converse with you in the past, and I have been waiting for the moment when I would be allowed. Indeed, you have hopes in the city of proving that you are more valuable to it than anyone, and of exercising immediate power over everything. So do I hope to exercise great power over you in just the same way, by proving that I am more valuable to you than anyone, and that neither guardian, nor kinsman, nor anyone else is up to the task

of granting you the power you desire except me, with the help of the god, of course. Now, when you were younger, before you were full of such aspirations, I think the god allowed no conversation in case I might have discoursed in vain. But he has now relented, for you may listen to me at this stage.

Alcibiades: Socrates, you seem even stranger to me now since you began to speak, than when you were following me in silence, although you were a strange sight even then. Now, it seems you have made up your mind about whether I have these intentions or not, and if I deny it, that will not do much to dissuade you. So be it, but if I really do have these intentions, how shall I attain them through you, and why will they not happen without you? Can you tell me?

106b

Socrates: So are you asking if I can deliver a long speech, the kind you are obviously accustomed to hearing? But that is not my way. However, I shall, I believe, be able to prove to you that this is how matters stand if you are willing to perform only one small service for me.

Alcibiades: Well, yes, I am willing, if the service you refer to is not a difficult one.

Socrates: Does it seem difficult to answer questions?

Alcibiades: No, it does not seem difficult.

Socrates: So answer then.

Alcibiades: Just ask.

Socrates: Should I ask questions on the basis that you do have the intentions I say you have?

106c

Alcibiades: Proceed on that basis if you wish, so that I may know what else you will say.

Socrates: Very well. Now, you intend, quite soon, to appear before the Athenians as an adviser. So if I were to take hold of you when you were about to ascend the platform and ask, “Alcibiades, what do the Athenians intend to deliberate about that you are standing up as an adviser? Is it about issues which you know better than they do?” What response would you make?

106d

Alcibiades: I would say that, of course. It is about issues I know better than they do.

Socrates: So you are a good adviser about issues you happen to know.

Alcibiades: How could I not be?

Socrates: Don’t you only know what you have learned from others or discovered yourself?

Alcibiades: What else could I know?

Socrates: Now, is there any way that you would ever have learned or discovered anything without wanting to learn it or investigate it yourself?

Alcibiades: There is not.

Socrates: What about this? Did you ever want to investigate or learn anything you thought you knew?

Alcibiades: Certainly not.

106e

Socrates: So was there a time when you did not think you knew whatever you now happen to know?

Alcibiades: There must have been.

Socrates: Well then, I know fairly well what it is that you have learned. If I omit anything you should tell me. Indeed, as I recall, you learned writing, lyre-playing and wrestling. And you

certainly had no desire to learn to play the flute³. These are the subjects you know, unless you have somehow been learning something without my noticing.

Alcibiades: No. I have not attended any classes other than those.

107a

Socrates: Well, will you stand forth as adviser to the Athenians when they are deliberating about writing and how they may write properly?

Alcibiades: By Zeus, I shall not.

Socrates: Or when they deliberate about sounds on the lyre?

Alcibiades: Not at all.

Socrates: Nor indeed are they in the habit of deliberating on wrestling in the assembly.

Alcibiades: No indeed.

Socrates: So what will they be deliberating about when you advise them, presumably not about house-building?

Alcibiades: Of course not.

Socrates: Because on these matters anyway, a housebuilder will give better advice than you.

107b

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Nor indeed when they are deliberating about a prophecy.

Socrates: For in those situations a soothsayer will advise better than you.

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Whether he is short or tall, beautiful or ugly, noble or base.

Alcibiades: That makes no difference.

Socrates: For counsel, I presume, belongs to the one who knows about the issue and not to the one who is wealthy.

Alcibiades: How could it be otherwise?

107c

Socrates: Then it makes no difference to the Athenians whether the adviser is poor or rich when they are deliberating on how the people of the city may enjoy health. No, they seek out a doctor to be the adviser.

Alcibiades: Quite likely.

Socrates: Now, what subject would they be considering when you would be justified in coming forward as their adviser?

Alcibiades: Whenever they are considering their own affairs, Socrates.

Socrates: Do you mean issues related to shipbuilding and what sort of ships they should get built?

Alcibiades: No, Socrates, I do not.

Socrates: And I think that is because you do not know how to build ships. Is this the reason or is there another?

Alcibiades: No, that is the reason.

Socrates: Then what aspect of their own affairs do you say they would be considering at the time?

107d

Alcibiades: When they are considering war, Socrates, or peace, or some other aspect of civic affairs.

Socrates: Do you mean when they are considering with whom they should make peace, and against whom they should wage

war, and in what manner?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And shouldn't they attack whomever it is better to attack?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And at the time when it is better to do so?

107e

Alcibiades: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And for as long a time as is better?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Now, if the Athenians were deciding with whom they should wrestle or spar, and in what manner, would you give better advice or would the trainer?

Alcibiades: The trainer, of course.

Socrates: Now, can you say what the trainer looks to when he is advising with whom they should wrestle or not, and when they should do so, and in what manner? What I am asking is this. Ought a person wrestle with those with whom it is better to wrestle, or not?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And to the extent that is better?

108a

Alcibiades: To that extent.

Socrates: And also at the time when it is better?

Alcibiades: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: What is more, when singing, one must on occasion play the lyre, or dance in accompaniment to the song.

Alcibiades: One must indeed.

Socrates: At the time when it is better to do so?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And to the extent that is better?

Alcibiades: I agree.

108b

Socrates: What about this? Since, in fact, you applied the term 'better' both to the lyre-playing in accompaniment to a song, and also to wrestling, what do you refer to as better in lyreplaying, just as I refer to what is better in wrestling, as gymnastical? What do you call it in lyre-playing?

Alcibiades: I do not understand.

Socrates: Then try to copy me. For in a way, the answer I gave is correct in general, and presumably, whatever happens in accord with a skill is correct. Is that so?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And wasn't the skill gymnastics?

Alcibiades: Of course.

108c

Socrates: And I said that in wrestling the better is the gymnastical.

Alcibiades: Yes, you said that.

Socrates: Was I not right in saying so?

Alcibiades: Well, I think so anyway.

Socrates: Then you should do this too, for right discourse is somehow particularly appropriate for you. Tell me first what skill includes lyre-playing, singing and dancing correctly? What is the collective skill called? Are you not yet able to say?

Alcibiades: Certainly not.

Socrates: Then try this. To which goddesses does the skill belong?

Alcibiades: Do you mean the Muses, Socrates?

108d

Socrates: I do indeed. Now, think. What skill derives its name from them?

Alcibiades: I think you mean music.

Socrates: Yes, that is what I mean. Now, what is the correct manner of proceeding based upon this skill? Just as in the previous example I told you the correct manner of proceeding based upon the skill of gymnastics, now I am asking you what you say in this case. How does the activity proceed?

Alcibiades: Musically, I suppose.

108e

Socrates: Well said. So come on, what do you call the better in the case of making war and in bringing peace? Just as in the previous example, you said that in one case the better was the more musical, and in the other case it was the more gymnastical, try also to say what is better in this example of war and peace.

Alcibiades: But I am not really able to say.

109a

Socrates: And yet, it would be somewhat shameful if someone you were advising about food, saying one is better than the other at this time and to this extent, were to ask, “Well now, Alcibiades, what do you mean by ‘better’?” And although you do not profess to be a doctor you were able to reply, on these matters, that you mean healthier. And yet, by contrast, in matters where you do profess to be knowledgeable and will come forward to give advice as though you had knowledge, wouldn’t you be ashamed if, as is likely, you were unable to respond when questioned about them? Or does this not appear

shameful?

Alcibiades: Very much so.

Socrates: Well, consider it and try to say, in the case of bringing peace and making war with the appropriate parties, what 'better' do they aim for?

Alcibiades: Well, I am considering it but I am unable to think of an answer.

Socrates: Do you not even know, in cases where we wage war, what accusations we make against one another as we go to war, and what we call this as we proceed?

109b

Alcibiades: Well, I do know that we claim to have been deceived or suffered violence or deprivation.

Socrates: That will do. In what way do we suffer each of these? Try to state the difference between this treatment and some other.

Alcibiades: Socrates, are you referring to whether it is done justly or unjustly?

Socrates: The very thing.

Alcibiades: Well then, they are completely and entirely different.

Socrates: In that case, whom will you advise the Athenians to wage war against, against those who are acting unjustly or those who are behaving justly?

109c

Alcibiades: You are asking a challenging question, Socrates, for even if someone did decide that he ought to wage war against those who are behaving justly, he would not admit this.

Socrates: Because this apparently is not lawful.

Alcibiades: Certainly not, nor does it seem to be noble.

Socrates: So will you also make speeches dealing with these issues?

Alcibiades: I must.

Socrates: With regard to waging war or not, those we should fight against and those we should not, when we should do so and when we should not, does ‘the better’ I was asking about turn out to be nothing but the more just? Or is this not so?

Alcibiades: It appears so anyway.

109d

Socrates: How can this be, dear Alcibiades? Have you forgotten that you yourself do not know this, or have you been learning without my noticing it and going to a teacher who taught you to distinguish the more just and the more unjust? Well, who is he? Tell me too, so that you may recommend me to him as a pupil.

Alcibiades: You are mocking me, Socrates.

Socrates: No I swear this by our common friendship⁴, and I would never break that oath. So if you can do so, tell me who he is.

109e

Alcibiades: But what if I can’t? Don’t you think I could know about the just and unjust in some other way?

Socrates: Yes, if you were to discover it.

Alcibiades: But don’t you think I could have discovered it?

Socrates: Yes, indeed, if you were to search for it.

Alcibiades: Oh! Do you not think I would have searched?

Socrates: I do indeed, if you thought you did not know.

Alcibiades: Well, was I not in that situation at some time?

110a

Socrates: That is well expressed. So are you able to say when it was that you did not know the just and the unjust? Come on, a year ago were you searching for them and did you think you did not know them? Or did you think you knew them then? And let your answer be the truth so that our discussions may not be conducted in vain.

Alcibiades: Well, I thought that I knew.

Socrates: And three, four or five years ago, was the situation not the same?

Alcibiades: I think so.

Socrates: And before that you were a child, is that so?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And yet, I know very well that you thought you knew then.

Alcibiades: How do you know so well?

110b

Socrates: As a child, either with your teachers or elsewhere and when you were playing dice or some other game, you did not act as if you were in doubt about the just and the unjust. No, I often heard you proclaiming loudly and boldly about one of the children that he was bad and unfair and that he was cheating. Or am I not speaking the truth?

Alcibiades: But what else was I to do, Socrates, when someone was cheating me?

Socrates: But if you were unaware at the time whether you were being cheated or not, would you ask what you ought to do?

110c

Alcibiades: But by Zeus, I was not unaware. No, I was fully aware that I was being treated unjustly.

Socrates: So apparently you thought you knew the just and the unjust even as a child.

Alcibiades: I thought I knew and I did actually know.

Socrates: Well, when exactly was it that you found this out? For obviously it was not during the time that you thought you knew, anyway.

Alcibiades: Of course not.

Socrates: Well, when was it that you thought you did not know? In fact, you will not discover when this was.

Alcibiades: Yes, by Zeus, Socrates, I really cannot say.

110d

Socrates: So you do not know them through discovering them for yourself.

Alcibiades: It certainly appears that way.

Socrates: And, indeed, you said earlier that you do not know from having learned either. Now, if you neither discovered this nor learned it, how do you know it and from what source?

Alcibiades: But perhaps I did not give you the right answer when I said that I know because I discovered them for myself.

Socrates: Then how did it happen?

Alcibiades: I think that I learned in the same way that everyone else learns.

Socrates: We have returned again to the same question. From whom? Please tell me.

110e

Alcibiades: From the multitude.

Socrates: You are not resorting to serious teachers when you have recourse to the multitude.

Alcibiades: But why? Are they not up to the task of teaching?

Socrates: Not even about how to play draughts and how not to! And yet, I believe these matters are more trivial than justice. What about you? Do you think so too?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Well, if they are unable to teach more trivial matters, could they teach more serious matters?

Alcibiades: Well, I think so. At any rate, they can teach numerous subjects more serious than draughts-playing.

Socrates: What are they?

111a

Alcibiades: For instance, I also learned to speak Greek from them and I would not be able to say who my own teacher was. Instead, I attribute this to the very people who you say are not serious teachers.

Socrates: Yes, noble friend, the multitude are good teachers of this subject and they may rightly be praised for their instruction in these matters.

Alcibiades: Why is that?

Socrates: Because in these matters they possess what good teachers ought to possess.

Alcibiades: What are you referring to?

111b

Socrates: Do you not appreciate that those who are going to teach anything at all must first know it themselves? Is this not so?

Alcibiades: How could it be otherwise?

Socrates: Shouldn't those who know agree with one another and not differ?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Would you say they have knowledge of subjects on which they disagree?

Alcibiades: Certainly not.

Socrates: So how could they be teachers of these subjects?

Alcibiades: In no way whatsoever.

111c

Socrates: Well now, do you think the multitude would differ about what wood and stone are like? And if you ask anyone, will they not agree on the same answer and reach for the same things when they wish to get wood or stone? And the same applies to everything else of that sort. Indeed, in general, that is what I understand you to mean by knowing how to speak Greek. Is this so?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Now, as we were saying, they agree with one another and with themselves individually on these issues, and the cities do not dispute with one another publicly, some saying one thing, others saying something else.

Alcibiades: They do not.

Socrates: So it is likely they would be good teachers of these matters anyway.

Alcibiades: Yes.

111d

Socrates: In that case, if we wanted to make someone knowledgeable about them, wouldn't we be right to send him for instruction by the 'multitude'?

Alcibiades: Entirely so.

Socrates: What if we wanted to know, not only what men are like and what horses are like, but also which of them are good at running and which are not, would the multitude still be competent to teach this?

Alcibiades: Not at all.

111e

Socrates: And you have sufficient evidence that they do not know and are not real teachers of these matters from the fact that they do not agree with themselves about them at all.

Alcibiades: I do indeed.

Socrates: What if we wanted to know, not only what men are like but also what healthy men or sick men are like, would the multitude be acceptable to us as teachers?

Alcibiades: Not at all.

Socrates: And you would have evidence that they are poor teachers of these matters if you had seen them disagreeing.

Alcibiades: I would.

Socrates: Well, what about this? Does it seem to you nowadays that the multitude agree with themselves and one another about just and unjust men and actions?

112a

Alcibiades: By Zeus, Socrates, not in the least.

Socrates: Do they, in fact, differ most about these matters?

Alcibiades: Very much so.

Socrates: Now, I am sure you have never seen or heard people disputing intensely in this way about health or its absence, so that they fought and killed one another because of it.

Alcibiades: Certainly not.

112b

Socrates: But when the issue is the just and the unjust, I know that even if you have not seen this, at least you have heard of it from many others, and from Homer, for you have heard the Iliad and the Odyssey.

Alcibiades: Yes of course, Socrates.

Socrates: Aren't those poems about a dispute over the just and unjust?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And the conflicts and the slayings took place because of this dispute between both Achaians and Trojans alike, and Odysseus and the suitors of Penelope too.

112c

Alcibiades: What you say is true.

Socrates: And I also think that a dispute about no other issue than the just and unjust gave rise to the slayings and conflicts of those Athenians, Spartans and Boeotians who died at Tanagra and later at Coronea, among whom your own father met his end. Is this so?

Alcibiades: What you say is true.

112d

Socrates: Now, should we say that these people have knowledge of matters on which they disagree so intensely that they dispute with one another and inflict these misfortunes on themselves?

Alcibiades: Apparently not.

Socrates: In that case, are you having recourse to teachers whom you agree are not knowledgeable?

Alcibiades: Quite likely.

Socrates: Then how are you likely to know the just and the unjust, a matter on which you are in such confusion and, as it

turns out, have neither learned from someone else nor discovered for yourself?

Alcibiades: Well, from what you are saying I am not likely to.

112e

Socrates: Do you also realise that you are not expressing this in the right way, Alcibiades?

Alcibiades: In what sense?

Socrates: You are claiming that I said these things.

Alcibiades: But are you not saying that I know nothing about the just and the unjust?

Socrates: Indeed not.

Alcibiades: Was it me?

Socrates: Yes.

Alcibiades: How so?

Socrates: You may know this in the following way. If I were to ask you which is greater, one or two, would you say two?

Alcibiades: I would.

Socrates: By how much is it greater?

Alcibiades: By one.

Socrates: Now, which of us is saying that two is greater than one, by one?

Alcibiades: I am.

Socrates: Did I not ask you and did you not answer?

Alcibiades: Yes.

113a

Socrates: Well then, is it I, the questioner, who turns out to be speaking about these matters or is it you, the answerer?

Alcibiades: It is I.

Socrates: What if I were to ask what letters spell ‘Socrates’ and you were to tell me, which of us would be the speaker?

Alcibiades: I would.

Socrates: So come on, to sum up, whenever there is questioning and answering, who is the speaker: the questioner or the answerer?

Alcibiades: It seems to me, anyway, that it is the answerer, Socrates.

113b

Socrates: Now, haven’t I been the questioner throughout?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And you were the answerer?

Alcibiades: Certainly.

Socrates: Well then, which of us said whatever was said?

Alcibiades: Apparently, Socrates, based on what has been agreed, I said it.

Socrates: Was it not said that Alcibiades the fair, the son of Clinias, did not know about the just and the unjust but thought that he did, and was about to go to the Assembly and advise the Athenians on matters he knows nothing about? Is this not the case?

Alcibiades: So it appears.

113c

Socrates: So the phrase from Euripides is applicable, Alcibiades. You have quite likely ‘heard this from yourself and not from me’⁵, and I am not the person making these statements. No, it is you, and you are blaming me without reason. Yet what you are saying is actually to the point. Indeed, you are planning to

embark on a mad undertaking, my friend, teaching what you do not know and have not bothered to learn.

113d

Alcibiades: Yet, Socrates, I believe that the Athenians and the other Greeks seldom deliberate upon whether something is more just or more unjust for they regard such questions as obvious. So they ignore this and consider whether the policies will have beneficial outcomes. In fact, I do not believe that the just and the beneficial are the same. No, many people have profited by performing great injustices, and others have, I believe, performed just actions and not benefited.

113e

Socrates: Well then, if the just is one thing and the beneficial happens to be something completely different, surely you do not believe that you also know what is beneficial to humanity and why it is so?

Alcibiades: What is to prevent me believing that, Socrates, unless you are going to go on and ask from whom I learned it or how I discovered it myself?

114a

Socrates: What a way to behave! If you say something incorrect and it happens to be capable of refutation by the very argument used before, you decide you need to hear some new and different refutations because the previous ones are like worn out garments which you would never wear. Instead, someone must provide you with a fresh and pristine proof. So I shall pay no attention to your attacks upon the argument and I shall ask you nonetheless. Where did you learn whatever you know about what is beneficial and who is your teacher? And I shall ask all those previous questions in a single question, otherwise you will obviously be in the same predicament and be unable to show that you know the beneficial either through discovering it or through learning it. But since you are being fastidious and

would not be pleased to taste the same argument once more, I shall bid farewell to the question of whether or not you know what is beneficial for the Athenians. Instead, why don't you explain whether the just and the beneficial are the same or different? If you prefer, you could question me just as I questioned you, or alternatively, just go through the argument by yourself.

Alcibiades: Well, Socrates, I do not know if I would be able to set out an argument for you.

Socrates: Then good fellow, regard me as the Assembly and the populace, for even in the Assembly you will need to convince each one. Is that so?

Alcibiades: Yes.

114c

Socrates: Isn't the same speaker able to convince one person, both individually and in gatherings, about whatever he knows, just as a schoolteacher, for instance, convinces one pupil about writing and also many pupils?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And in the case of arithmetic, won't the same person convince both one and many?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And will that be the person who knows, namely the arithmetician?

Alcibiades: Certainly.

Socrates: And is it not also the case that on the very issues on which you can convince many people, you can also convince one person?

Alcibiades: Quite likely.

Socrates: And obviously these are issues that you know.

Alcibiades: Yes.

114d

Socrates: Then someone in a gathering like this differs from a public speaker only insofar as one persuades groups about the same things, while the other does it individually.

Alcibiades: Probably.

Socrates: Well then, since it turns out that the same speaker convinces both many and one, practise on me and attempt to prove that the just is sometimes not beneficial.

Alcibiades: You are overbearing, Socrates!

Socrates: Then perhaps overbearingly, I am going to convince you of the opposite of what you do not want to prove to me.

Alcibiades: Please proceed.

Socrates: You need only answer the questions.

114e

Alcibiades: No, you yourself should be the speaker.

Socrates: What is this! Don't you want to be completely convinced?

Alcibiades: Entirely so, of course.

Socrates: Well, if you yourself say that these things are so, won't you be completely convinced?

Alcibiades: I think so anyway.

Socrates: Then please answer, and if you yourself do not hear from yourself that whatever is just is also beneficial, you should not believe it from any other speaker either.

Alcibiades: No indeed, but I must answer, and, in fact, I do not think I can come to any harm.

115a

Socrates: How prophetic you are! Now, tell me, are you saying that some just actions are beneficial while others are not?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And are some of them noble while others are not?

Alcibiades: What are you asking me?

Socrates: I am asking if you ever thought that someone acted ignobly and yet justly?

Alcibiades: No, I did not.

Socrates: Then all that is just is also noble?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: But what about noble actions? Are they all good or are some good while others are not?

Alcibiades: Well, Socrates, I think that some noble actions are bad.

Socrates: And some that are ignoble are also good?

Alcibiades: Yes.

115b

Socrates: Do you mean something like this? In war, for instance, many people have come to the rescue of a companion or kinsman and have sustained injuries or been killed, while those who did not come to the rescue, but should have, came away safe and sound.

Alcibiades: Yes, entirely so.

Socrates: Do you call such a rescue noble on account of the attempt to save those whom one should save, and is this, in turn, courage? Is that it?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Then the rescue is bad on account of the deaths and the injuries, is it?

Alcibiades: Yes.

115c

Socrates: Now, is not courage one thing and death another?

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: So the rescue of friends is not noble and bad on account of the same thing at any rate.

Alcibiades: Apparently not.

Socrates: Then consider whether in these particular examples it is also good, at least to the extent that it is noble. We agree that the rescue is noble on account of the courage. Now, consider this courage itself, is it good or bad? Think about it as follows: which would you rather have, what is good or what is bad?

Alcibiades: What is good.

Socrates: Especially the greatest goods?

115d

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And you would be most reluctant to be deprived of such things.

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: Now, what do you say about courage? At what price would you accept being deprived of this?

Alcibiades: I would not even be prepared to go on living if I were a coward.

Socrates: Then you think cowardice is the worst of evils.

Alcibiades: I do.

Socrates: Equal to death, so it seems.

Alcibiades: I agree.

Socrates: Now, are not life and courage the direct opposites of death and cowardice?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And would you most like to have the first two and least like to have the other two?

115e

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Is that because you regard one pair as the best and the other as the worst?

Alcibiades: Entirely so.

Socrates: Then you count courage among the best and death among the worst.

Alcibiades: I do.

Socrates: Then you refer to the rescue of friends in battle as noble in so far as it is noble based upon the good outcome, the courageous outcome.

Alcibiades: Apparently I do.

Socrates: But on the other hand, based upon the bad outcome, death, you say it is bad.

Alcibiades: Yes.

116a

Socrates: Accordingly, it is right to describe each of the outcomes as follows. If, in fact, you call it bad in so far as it gives rise to badness, you must also call it good in so far as it gives rise to goodness.

Alcibiades: I think so anyway.

Socrates: In that case, is it noble in so far as it is good and ignoble in so far as it is bad?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: So saying that the rescue of friends in battle is noble and yet bad is not at all different from saying that it is good and yet bad.

Alcibiades: I think what you say is true, Socrates.

116b

Socrates: Then nothing that is noble, in so far as it is noble, is bad; nor is anything that is ignoble, in so far as it is ignoble, good.

Alcibiades: Apparently not.

Socrates: Then you also need to consider this. Does not anyone who acts nobly also act well?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And those who act well are happy?

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: Are they not happy due to the acquisition of whatever is good?

Alcibiades: Definitely.

Socrates: And do they acquire this by acting well and nobly?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: So acting well is good?

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: Is not acting well noble?

Alcibiades: Yes.

116c

Socrates: So, once again, the same thing appears to us to be both noble and good.

Alcibiades: It appears so.

Socrates: So, on the basis of this argument anyway, that which we find to be noble we shall also find to be good.

Alcibiades: We must.

Socrates: What about this? Are good things beneficial or not?

Alcibiades: They are beneficial.

Socrates: Now, do you recall what we agreed concerning just actions?

Alcibiades: Well, I think we agreed that those who act justly must also be acting nobly.

Socrates: And also, that those performing noble actions are also performing good actions?

Alcibiades: Yes.

116d

Socrates: And whatever is good is beneficial?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Then just actions are beneficial, Alcibiades.

Alcibiades: So it seems.

Socrates: Well now, have you not been the speaker and I the questioner throughout this?

Alcibiades: Apparently I am, or so it seems.

116e

Socrates: Now, if anyone who thinks he knows the just and the unjust stands up to advise the Athenians or Peperethians⁶, but goes on to say that the just is sometimes bad, what could you do but laugh at him, especially since you yourself happen to be

asserting that the just and the beneficial are the same?

Alcibiades: But by the gods, Socrates, I do not even know what I am saying myself. No, I really do not know where I stand. For under your questioning, I think one thing at one moment and a different thing the next.

Socrates: Are you unaware then, my friend, of what this predicament is?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Well, if someone were to ask you if you have two eyes or three, two hands or four, or another question of that sort, do you imagine you would answer in one way at one moment and a different way the next, or would it always be the same?

117a

Alcibiades: Well, I am anxious about myself at the moment. Nevertheless, I think I would give the same answer.

Socrates: And that is because you know. Is that not the reason?

Alcibiades: I think so anyway.

Socrates: So when it comes to issues on which you cannot help giving contradictory answers, it is obvious that you do not know about these.

117b

Alcibiades: So it seems anyway.

Socrates: Now, do you not say that you are confused when answering questions concerning the just and the unjust, the noble and the ignoble, the bad and the good, and what is beneficial and what is not? Is it not obvious then that you are confused on these issues because you do not know about them?

Alcibiades: I think so.

Socrates: Well, is it indeed the case that when someone does not know something his soul must be confused about this?

Alcibiades: Inevitably.

Socrates: What about this? Do you know any means whereby you could go up into the sky?

Alcibiades: By Zeus, I do not.

Socrates: And is your thinking confused about these matters?

Alcibiades: Certainly not.

Socrates: And do you know the reason or shall I tell you?

Alcibiades: Tell me.

Socrates: Because, my friend, you do not think that you know this when you do not know this.

Alcibiades: Again, what do you mean?

117c

Socrates: Let us look at this together. There are things you do not know and realise that you do not know, but are you confused about such matters? For instance, surely you know that you do not know about food preparation?

Alcibiades: Entirely so.

Socrates: Now, in such matters do you yourself think about how it should be prepared and get confused, or do you hand over to someone who knows?

Alcibiades: I hand over.

117d

Socrates: And what if you were in a ship, would you think about whether the tiller should be drawn in or out and get confused since you do not know, or would you stay quiet and hand over to the helmsman?

Alcibiades: To the helmsman.

Socrates: So you are not confused over what you do not know provided you know that you do not know.

Alcibiades: It seems I am not.

Socrates: Now, do you appreciate that errors in action are also due to this ignorance whereby you think you know when you do not know?

Alcibiades: Once more, what do you mean by this?

Socrates: When we undertake an action, presumably we think, at the time, that we know what we are doing?

Alcibiades: Yes.

117e

Socrates: Yes, and I suppose that people who think that they do not know entrust the matter to others?

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: Now, do not people of this sort live free from error even though they do not know, because they turn to other people in dealing with these matters?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: So who are the people who make the errors? For I presume it is not the people who know.

Alcibiades: Of course not.

118a

Socrates: And since it is neither those who know, nor those who do not know and know that they do not know, who else is left except those who do not know but think that they know?

Alcibiades: No one but these.

Socrates: So, is the ignorance itself the cause of the evils and is this stupidity a matter of reproach?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And when it involves the most important matters, is it then productive of the greatest evil and is it most dishonourable?

Alcibiades: Very much so.

Socrates: Well then, can you name anything more important than what is just, noble, good and beneficial?

Alcibiades: Certainly not.

Socrates: And are you saying that you are confused about these?

Alcibiades: Yes.

118b

Socrates: But if you are confused, is it not evident from the previous discussion that not only are you ignorant of the most important matters, but you also think that you know about them when you do not know?

Alcibiades: There is that danger.

118c

Socrates: My, oh my, Alcibiades, what a predicament you are in! I am reluctant to name it, and yet since we are alone, it has to be said. Best of men, you are wedded to the most extreme ignorance. The argument convicts you and you convict yourself. Because of this, you rush into politics before you have been educated. And you are not the only one in this plight, so also are most of those who engage in the affairs of this city, save but a few, and perhaps your guardian, Pericles.

Alcibiades: You know, Socrates, they say he did not become wise by mere chance, but from association with numerous wise men including Pythoclides and Anaxagoras⁷. And now that he is older, he still consorts with Damon for this very purpose.

Socrates: Well now, have you ever seen anyone who was in any way wise, being incapable of making another person wise in the same things as himself? Just as the man who taught you writing was himself wise and he made you, and anyone else he wanted to, wise – is this so?

Alcibiades: Yes.

118d

Socrates: And now that you have learned from him, will you not be able to teach someone else?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And does the same apply to the lyre player and the trainer?

Alcibiades: Entirely so.

Socrates: For it surely constitutes good evidence that those who know anything, do actually know it when they are also able to make another person knowledgeable.

Alcibiades: Yes, I think so.

Socrates: Well now, can you say of Pericles that he made someone wise? Let us begin with his own sons.

118e

Alcibiades: But, Socrates, what if both Pericles' sons were born stupid?

Socrates: Then what about your brother Clinias?

Alcibiades: Again why do you mention Clinias when the man is insane?

Socrates: Well, since Clinias is insane and both Pericles' sons were born stupid, what blame might we assign in your case? How did he overlook the condition you are in?

Alcibiades: I think I am to blame for not being interested.

119a

Socrates: But can you name anyone, citizen or stranger, slave or free man, who is reputed to have become wiser due to his association with Pericles, just as I can name Pythodorus, the son of Isolochus, and Callias, the son of Calliades⁸, each of whom has become both wise and famous through association with Zeno, having paid him one hundred minae?

Alcibiades: By Zeus, I cannot.

Socrates: So be it. In that case, what have you in mind for yourself? Do you intend to remain as you are or take some care?

119b

Alcibiades: Let us take counsel together, Socrates! And yet, I do understand what you are saying and I agree. Indeed, it does seem to me that those who conduct the affairs of this city, with a few exceptions, are uneducated.

Socrates: What are the consequences of this?

Alcibiades: Well, if they had been educated, I suppose that anyone trying to compete against them would need to go about it after learning and having practised as though he were competing with athletes. But now, since these people embark upon civic affairs in the character of common folk, what need is there to practise or to take the trouble to learn? In fact, I know very well that by nature I shall be far superior to them.

119c

Socrates: My, oh my! What a thing to say, best of men, and how unworthy of your character and your other endowments.

Alcibiades: Why exactly are you saying this, Socrates, and what are you referring to?

Socrates: I am troubled for you and for my own love.

Alcibiades: Tell me why.

Socrates: Troubled that you regard the men of this city as worthy competition.

Alcibiades: But who am I competing against?

Socrates: A man who believes he has a great intellect deserves to ask this question.

119d

Alcibiades: What do you mean? Am I not in competition with these people?

119e

Socrates: But if you were intending to steer a trireme about to go into battle, would you be content to be the best of your fellow sailors at steering? Or would you assume that this must be the case and look instead to your true adversaries, rather than, as now, to your comrades in arms? Indeed, if you really intend to exhibit some noble action worthy of yourself and the city, you will of course need to be superior to these fellows, so that although they are unworthy to compete against you, they will fight with you against the enemy in spite of your contempt.

Alcibiades: Well, yes, that is my intention anyway.

Socrates: So, is it really worth your while to rest content when you are better than the soldiers, rather than looking to the leaders on the opposing side, once you have become better than the soldiers by planning and exercising with them?

Alcibiades: Who are these leaders you are referring to, Socrates?

120a

Socrates: Do you not know that our city wages war on occasion against the Spartans and the Great King?

Alcibiades: That is true.

Socrates: Well, if you really intend to be a ruler of this city, would it not be right to consider yourself in competition with

the kings of Sparta and Persia?

Alcibiades: What you are saying is probably true.

120b

Socrates: Goodness no! You should look instead to Meidias⁹, the quail-fighter, and others of that sort who attempt to manage the affairs of the city still bearing the mark of the slave in their soul; the servile haircut, as the women say. This is due to their ill-education, and before they have cast this off whilst still in their barbarous ways, they come to the city as flatterers rather than rulers. If you look to these people, the ones I am describing, you must perforce neglect yourself and neither learn whatever there is to learn in preparation for so great a contest, nor practise what needs to be practised, and embark upon civic affairs having undergone comprehensive preparation.

120c

Alcibiades: Yes, Socrates, I think you are speaking the truth. However, I believe the Spartan generals and the Persian King are no better than the rest.

Socrates: Best of men, consider the nature of this belief you are holding.

Alcibiades: In what respect?

120d

Socrates: Firstly, do you think you would show better care for yourself through fearing them and regarding them as formidable, or through not doing so?

Alcibiades: Obviously, if I were to regard them as formidable.

Socrates: Now, you surely do not think that any harm will come from caring for yourself?

Alcibiades: Not at all, I shall be greatly benefited.

Socrates: Well, to this extent, is there not one problem with this belief of yours?

Alcibiades: What you say is true.

Socrates: And secondly, you should consider the likelihood that the belief is also false.

Alcibiades: How so?

120e

Socrates: Are better natures likely to arise among high-born families or not?

Alcibiades: Obviously among the high-born.

Socrates: Now, would these good natures also become completely excellent once they receive a good upbringing?

Alcibiades: They must.

Socrates: Well, let us consider this. Firstly, comparing our own lineage to theirs, do the kings of Sparta and Persia seem to come from ordinary families? Or do we not know that one is descended from Heracles, the other from Achaemenes, both of whom trace their lineage back to Perseus, son of Zeus?

121a

Alcibiades: Yes, Socrates, and ours goes back to Eurysaces¹⁰, and the line of Eurysaces goes back to Zeus.

121b

Socrates: And, indeed, high-born Alcibiades, mine goes back to Daedalus¹¹, and Daedalus to Hephaestus, son of Zeus. But the lineage of these people, starting with themselves, is a line of kings back as far as Zeus, kings of Argos and Sparta on the one hand, perpetual kings of Persia on the other and indeed sometime kings of Asia just as they are at present, while we ourselves are but common folk and so were our fathers too. And if you had to place the ancestry of Eurysaces and his fatherland, Salamis, on display before Artaxerxes, son of Xerxes, or show

him Aegina, the fatherland of the more ancient Aeacus¹², think how much laughter you would provoke. Yes, behold how inferior we are to these men in pride of family and general development. Or have you not observed the endowments of the Spartan kings, kings whose wives are guarded in public by the Ephors as best they can, lest a king be born unwittingly of someone not belonging to the Heraclidae? While the Persian King is so superior that no one suspects that he could have been born from anyone but a king, and so the king's wife is protected by nothing apart from fear. When the eldest son is born, the one who will rule, first of all, everyone in the city where the king rules has a celebration. Then, in the following year on the same day, all Asia sacrifices and celebrates the birthday of the king. But when you and I were born, Alcibiades, as the comic poet says, not even the neighbours were really aware of it¹³. The child is reared subsequently, not by a female nurse of little importance, but by those eunuchs in the king's service who are deemed most excellent. The overall care of the newborn child is assigned to these men, and they must ensure that he will be as handsome as possible by shaping and straightening the child's limbs. And the eunuchs who do this are held in high regard. Once the children reach seven years of age, they spend time with horses and with riding instructors and they begin to go hunting. And at fourteen years of age, they hand the child over to men whom they call 'the royal educators'. These are four men of the right age selected from Persians with the best reputations: the wisest, the most just, the most sound-minded and the bravest. The first teaches the magic of Zoroaster¹⁴, the son of Horomazus, and this is the worship of gods, but he also teaches the business of a king. The most just teaches him to speak the truth throughout his entire life. The most sound-minded teaches him never to be ruled by a single pleasure so that he may get used to being free and truly a king, ruling first of all over whatever is within himself, without being

enslaved. The bravest renders him fearless and confident, telling him that he is a slave whenever he is afraid. However, in your case, Alcibiades, Pericles placed you under an instructor, Zopyrus of Thrace, one of his household slaves who was utterly useless on account of his old age. I would also have described the general development and education of your adversaries were it not a major task. Anyway, these details are sufficient to demonstrate any other aspects that follow from them. But you could say, Alcibiades, that no one, unless he happens to be a lover of yours, cares about your birth or development or education or that of any other Athenian. What is more, if you wish to cast an eye on the wealth and luxury, the clothes and flowing garments, the scented unguents, the vast retinue of servants and the general refinement of the Persians, you will be ashamed of yourself, realising how far we lag behind them. And if you were to go on and look at the self-restraint and orderliness, the dexterity and agility, high-mindedness, discipline, courage and endurance of the Spartans and their love for work, victory and honour, you would think yourself but a child in all such matters. And if you also turn your mind to wealth and believe that you are significant in that regard, we should not let that go without a mention either, if you are somehow to be aware of where you stand. Yes, in this case, if you cared to look at the wealth of the Spartans, you would realise that ours falls far short of theirs. For the amount of land they possess, their own and that of the Messenians, and the vastness and excellence of what is there, would never be disputed by anyone at all; nor again would their ownership of slaves in general and of helots, horses too, and whatever herds of animals graze around Messene. But let us leave all these details aside, yet there is not as much gold and silver in all Greece as there is in private hands in Sparta. For over many generations, gold and silver have flowed into Sparta from all of the Greeks and often from non-Greeks too, but they never flow

out again. So it really accords with the story of Aesop where the fox speaks to the lion; the footprints of the money going in to Sparta go in a direction which is plain to see, but nowhere may they be seen coming out. So we should be well aware that the people there are the wealthiest of the Greeks in gold and silver, and among themselves the king is the richest, for the largest and most numerous allocations of such funds belong to the kings, and yet the royal grant which the Spartans pay to their kings is not insignificant either. And although Spartan wealth is enormous compared to that of the Greeks, it is nothing in comparison to the wealth of Persia and their king. I once heard a trustworthy man, one of those who travelled up to the king, who said that he traversed a very extensive tract of good land, almost a day's journey, which the locals call 'the girdle of the king's wife'; and there is also another tract which they, in this case, call 'her veil', and numerous other beautiful and good places have been selected for the adornment of the woman, and each of the places bears the name of the particular adornments. So I believe that if someone were to say to the king's mother, Amestris, the wife of Xerxes, "The son of Dinomache¹⁵ intends to pit himself against your son; her raiment is worth perhaps fifty minae or somewhat more, and her son owns three hundred acre¹⁶s or so at Erchia", she would wonder what precisely this Alcibiades trusts in when he proposes to compete against Artaxerxes. And I think she would say this man is making his attempt trusting in nothing else except care and wisdom, for that is all the Greeks have that is worth mentioning. What if she were then to find out that this Alcibiades is now making his attempt, firstly, when he is not yet fully twenty years of age; secondly, when he is entirely uneducated; and furthermore, although his lover tells him that he should go into competition against the king after he has learned, cared for himself and practised, he does not want to do this, but says that he is satisfied as he is? I think she would be amazed and would ask,

“Well, what on earth is it that this young man trusts in?” And if we were to say that it is beauty, strength, family, wealth and the natural endowments of his soul, she would think we were mad, Alcibiades, when she looked at all these qualities in comparison with what they themselves possess. But I also think that Lampido, the daughter of Leotychides, wife of Archidamus and mother of Agis¹⁷, all of whom have been kings, would indeed be amazed when she looked at the endowments which they have, amazed that you intend to compete against her son when you have been so badly brought up. What is more, do you not think it is a disgrace that the wives of our enemies have a better understanding of us and the sort of people we need to be in order to take them on, than we have of our own selves? So, blessed man, be persuaded by me and by the inscription at Delphi, ‘Know thyself’, and know that our adversaries are these kings and not those whom you regard as such. And we shall never prevail over them in any other way save through care and skill, and if you are found wanting in these you will be found wanting in reputation among the Greeks and non-Greeks, and I think you love that more than anyone else loves anything.

Alcibiades: Well, Socrates, what attention is required? Can you elaborate? Indeed, what you have said seems to be entirely true.

124c

Socrates: Yes, but we really should deliberate together as to the way in which we may become as good as possible. For when I say that it is necessary to be educated, I am not just referring to you and excluding myself. Indeed, I am better than you in no way save one.

Alcibiades: In what way?

Socrates: My guardian is better and wiser than your Pericles.

Alcibiades: Who is he, Socrates?

Socrates: A god, Alcibiades, the very one who would not allow me to converse with you until today, the god in whom I trust when I say that you will never become illustrious except through me.

124d

Alcibiades: You are joking, Socrates!

Socrates: Perhaps, but I am speaking the truth when I say that we do require care, or more to the point, all men do but we two need it very much.

Alcibiades: You are not lying when you say that I need it.

Socrates: Nor in my own case either.

Alcibiades: What should we do now?

Socrates: We should neither give up nor prove cowards, my friend.

Alcibiades: No, that would not be appropriate, Socrates.

124e

Socrates: No indeed. Instead we should consider this together. So tell me, we say that we wish to become as excellent as possible, do we not?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: What is that excellence?

Alcibiades: The very excellence by which men are good men, of course.

Socrates: Men who are good in what?

Alcibiades: Obviously in performing actions.

Socrates: What sort of actions? Those related to horses?

Alcibiades: Of course not.

Socrates: In that case we would be compared with horse trainers.

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Then are you referring to nautical affairs?

Socrates: In that case we would be compared with seamen.

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: What sort of actions then? Actions performed by whom?

Alcibiades: Those performed by the noble and good among the Athenians.

Socrates: And do you refer to people with understanding, or people without it, as noble and good?

125a

Alcibiades: Those with understanding.

Socrates: Isn't each person good at whatever he understands?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And bad at what he does not understand?

Alcibiades: He must be.

Socrates: Now, does the cobbler have understanding about making shoes?

Alcibiades: Certainly.

Socrates: So, is he good in this respect?

Alcibiades: Yes, good.

Socrates: What about this? Is not the cobbler devoid of understanding about making clothes?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: So is he bad in this respect?

125b

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: So by this argument anyway, the same person is bad and also good.

Alcibiades: So it appears.

Socrates: Now, are you really saying that good men are also bad?

Alcibiades: Indeed not.

Socrates: Then who precisely do you call ‘the good’?

Alcibiades: I mean those who are able to rule in the city.

Socrates: Not over horses, I presume?

Alcibiades: Indeed not.

Socrates: But over men?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: When they are ill?

Socrates: When they are at sea then?

Alcibiades: I am not saying that either.

Socrates: When they are harvesting?

Socrates: Well, is it when they are doing something, or doing nothing?

125c

Alcibiades: I mean when they are doing something.

Socrates: Doing what? Try to give me an example.

Alcibiades: Well, he rules over those who are co-operating among themselves and dealing with one another, just as we do when we are living in the cities.

Socrates: Are you saying then that he rules over people who are dealing with people?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Is it over boatswains who are dealing with rowers?

Alcibiades: Not at all.

Socrates: Indeed, that excellence is helmsmanship itself.

Alcibiades: Yes.

125d

Socrates: Then do you mean he rules over men who are playing pipes, who are leading people in song and dealing with choristers?

Alcibiades: Not at all.

Socrates: Yes. That for its part is the choirmaster's skill itself, is it not?

Alcibiades: Certainly.

Socrates: Then what precisely do you mean by being able to rule over people who are dealing with people?

Alcibiades: I mean they rule over people in the city who are sharing in civic life and co-operating with one another.

Socrates: And what is the actual skill? It is as if I were repeating the question I asked just now. What skill enables him to know how to rule over men who are sharing a sea voyage?

Alcibiades: Helmsmanship.

125e

Socrates: And in the example we have just given, what knowledge enables him to rule over those who are sharing in song?

Alcibiades: Exactly what you just said, the choirmaster's skill.

Socrates: What about this? What do you call the knowledge of ruling over those who share in civic life?

Alcibiades: I would call it sound judgement, Socrates.

Socrates: Yes, but is the knowledge of the helmsman poor judgement?

Alcibiades: Not at all.

Socrates: Is it sound judgement, then?

126a

Alcibiades: I think so, in relation to preserving the sea-farers anyway.

Socrates: Well said! What about this? The sound judgement you are referring to, to what is it directed?

Alcibiades: To better manage and preserve the city.

Socrates: And it is better managed and preserved through the presence or absence of what? It is as if you were to ask me, “The body is better managed and preserved through the presence or absence of what?” I would reply that it is through the presence of health and the absence of disease. Do you not also think the same way?

126b

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And if you were to go on and ask, “Through the presence of what are the eyes better?” I would answer in the same way, that it is through the presence of sight and the absence of blindness. And the ears become better and are better served through the absence of deafness and the operation of hearing within them.

Alcibiades: And rightly so.

Socrates: Yes, and a city becomes better and is better served and managed through the presence or absence of what?

126c

Alcibiades: Well, it seems to me, Socrates, that this happens when they have friendship towards one another, and hatred and strife are absent.

Socrates: Now, by friendship do you mean agreement or disagreement?

Alcibiades: Agreement.

Socrates: Now, through what skill do the cities agree about number?

Alcibiades: Through arithmetic.

Socrates: And in the case of individuals, do they not agree through the same skill?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And does not each person also agree with himself through this?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And through what skill does each person agree with himself as to which is greater, a span or a cubit¹⁸? Is it not through measurement?

126d

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: And do not the individuals and the cities agree with one another through this skill?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Yes, and does not the same also apply to weighing?

Alcibiades: I agree.

Socrates: Well then, what is the agreement you refer to, what is it about and what skill brings it about? And is agreement in a

city and in an individual the very same, both in relation to itself and in relation to another?

Alcibiades: Yes, that is likely anyway.

Socrates: Well, what is it? Do not be reluctant to answer. Be eager to speak.

126e

Alcibiades: Well, I think I am referring to friendship and agreement whereby a father and mother agree in loving a son, or brother agrees with brother, or a woman with a man.

Socrates: Now, Alcibiades, do you think a man would be able to agree with a woman about woolspinning when he is not knowledgeable and she is knowledgeable?

Alcibiades: Of course not.

Socrates: Nor is it necessary either, for this is a feminine branch of learning.

Alcibiades: Yes.

127a

Socrates: What about this, would a woman be able to agree with a man about soldiering when she has not learned this?

Alcibiades: Of course not.

Socrates: For you would probably say that this, in turn, is a masculine pursuit.

Alcibiades: I would.

Socrates: So according to your argument, there are manly and womanly subjects.

Alcibiades: How could there not be?

Socrates: So, in these cases anyway, there is no agreement between women and men.

Socrates: Nor is there friendship either, if, in fact, friendship is agreement.

Alcibiades: Apparently not.

Socrates: So, to the extent that women do what belongs to themselves, they are not loved by men.

Alcibiades: It seems not.

127b

Socrates: So, men are not loved by women either, to the extent that they do what belongs to themselves.

Socrates: And are cities not well organised either, whenever each person does what belongs to himself?

Alcibiades: I think they are, Socrates.

Socrates: Do you mean when friendship is absent? Did we not say that cities are well organised when friendship arises within them, and not otherwise?

Alcibiades: But it seems to me, on this basis, that friendship arises between them because both are doing what belongs to themselves.

127c

Socrates: This was not so a moment ago! What are you saying now? When agreement is not in place does friendship arise? Or can agreement be in place on matters which some people know about while others do not?

Alcibiades: That is impossible.

Socrates: But when each person does what belongs to himself, do they perform just actions or unjust actions?

Alcibiades: Just actions, how could they not?

Socrates: Now, when the citizens of a city are performing just actions, doesn't friendship towards one another arise?

Alcibiades: Again I think this is inevitable, Socrates.

127d

Socrates: Now, what precisely do you mean by the friendship and agreement about which we must be wise and judge soundly so that we may be good men? Indeed, I have been unable to understand either what it is or who has it, for according to your argument, it seems to be present one moment and absent the next moment in the same people.

Alcibiades: Well, by the gods, Socrates, I do not even know what I mean myself, and, in fact, I have probably been in an utterly shameful condition for some time without being aware of this myself.

127e

Socrates: But you must take courage! If you had noticed this predicament at the age of fifty it would have been difficult for you to care for yourself. But now you are at the right age, the very age at which you should be aware of this.

Alcibiades: And what should someone who is aware of this do, Socrates?

Socrates: Answer the questions you are asked, Alcibiades. And if you do this and God wills it and you trust in my prophecy when necessary, you and I shall fare better.

Alcibiades: As far as my answering is concerned anyway, this will happen.

128a

Socrates: Come on then, let us ask what ‘care for yourself’ is, and when a person does this, in case we are unwittingly not caring for our own selves whilst thinking that we are. Whenever he cares for what belongs to himself, does he also care for himself?

Alcibiades: Well, I think so anyway.

Socrates: What about this? When is a person caring for his feet? Is it when he cares for those things that belong to his feet?

Alcibiades: I do not understand.

Socrates: But do you refer to anything as belonging to the hand? A ring, for instance, would you say that it belongs to any part of a man except his finger?

Alcibiades: Certainly not.

Socrates: Does not a shoe belong to the foot in the same way?

Alcibiades: Yes.

128b

Socrates: Now, whenever we are caring for our shoes, are we at that time caring for our feet?

Alcibiades: I do not fully understand, Socrates.

Socrates: What about this, Alcibiades? Do you refer to any matter as ‘properly cared for’?

Alcibiades: I do.

Socrates: Now, whenever something is made better, do you call this ‘proper care’?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Well, what skill makes shoes better?

Alcibiades: Cobbling.

Socrates: So we attend to shoes through cobbling?

Alcibiades: Yes.

128c

Socrates: Do we care for our feet also through cobbling or through that skill by which we make our feet better?

Alcibiades: By that skill.

Socrates: And are not feet made better by that which also makes the rest of the body better?

Alcibiades: I think so anyway.

Socrates: And is that not gymnastics?

Alcibiades: Definitely.

Socrates: So do we care for the feet through gymnastics, and to what belongs to the feet through cobbling?

Alcibiades: Certainly.

Socrates: And do we care for the hands by gymnastics, and to what belongs to the hand by ringmaking?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And do we care for the body by gymnastics, and to what belongs to the body by weaving and the other skills?

128d

Alcibiades: Entirely so.

Socrates: So we care for the thing itself by one skill, and to what belongs to it by a different skill.

Alcibiades: So it appears.

Socrates: Then you would not be caring for yourself whenever you are caring for what belongs to yourself.

Alcibiades: Not at all.

Socrates: For it seems that the skill whereby someone may care for himself, and to what belongs to himself, is not the same.

Alcibiades: It appears not.

Socrates: Come on then, by what kind of skill could we ever care for our own selves?

Alcibiades: I am unable to say.

128e

Socrates: Well, have we agreed this much anyway, that this is not a skill by which we could make anything that belongs to us better, but one whereby we could make ourselves better?

Alcibiades: What you say is true.

Socrates: Now, could we ever recognise what skill makes a shoe better, without knowing a shoe?

Alcibiades: Impossible.

Socrates: Nor what skill makes a finger better, without recognising a finger?

Alcibiades: True.

Socrates: What about this? Could we ever know what skill makes ourselves better, if we did not recognise what precisely we ourselves are?

Alcibiades: Impossible.

129a

Socrates: Now, is it the case that to 'know thyself' is easy, and was it some ordinary person who set up this inscription in the temple at Delphi, or is it difficult and not for everybody?

Alcibiades: Socrates, I have often thought that it is for everybody, and often that it is extremely difficult.

Socrates: Well, Alcibiades, whether it is easy or difficult, here is where we stand anyway. If we know it, we would be likely to know this 'care for ourselves', but without knowing it, we could never do so.

Alcibiades: That is so.

129b

Socrates: Come then, by what means might we find the self itself? For in this way we may likely find what precisely we ourselves are, but while we are still in ignorance of this, we

would presumably be unable to do so.

Alcibiades: What you are saying is correct.

Socrates: Stop there, by Zeus! To whom are you talking now?
To no one except me?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Am I not also talking to you?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: So, is Socrates the one who is talking?

Alcibiades: Definitely.

Socrates: And is Alcibiades the listener?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Does not Socrates talk using speech?

129c

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: And I suppose you call talking and using speech the same thing.

Alcibiades: Definitely.

Socrates: And is not the user different from that which is used?

Alcibiades: What do you mean?

Socrates: For example, a cobbler presumably cuts leather with a curved blade, a knife and other instruments.

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: So on the one hand, there is the person who uses the instruments and cuts the leather, and on the other hand there are the instruments with which he does the cutting.

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: In the same way, the instruments with which the lyre player plays the lyre would be different from the lyre player himself, would they not?

Alcibiades: Yes.

129d

Socrates: That is what I was asking you just now. Does the user always seem to be different from what he uses?

Alcibiades: So it seems.

Socrates: Now, what else can we say about the cobbler? Does he cut using the instruments alone or using his hands too?

Alcibiades: His hands too.

Socrates: So, he also uses these?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And does he also cut leather using his eyes?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And we agree that the user is different from that which is used?

Alcibiades: Yes.

129e

Socrates: So, are the cobbler and lyre player different from the hands and eyes with which they perform actions?

Alcibiades: It appears so.

Socrates: Does not a person actually make use of the entire body?

Alcibiades: Certainly.

Socrates: Did we say the user is different from what is used?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: So, is a person different from his own body?

Alcibiades: So it seems.

Socrates: Then what precisely is the person?

Alcibiades: I cannot say.

Socrates: Well, you can say, at any rate, that he is the user of the body.

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Now, does anything else use it except the soul?

130a

Alcibiades: Nothing else.

Socrates: In that case, does the soul rule?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And, indeed, I think no one could come to any conclusion except the following.

Alcibiades: What conclusion?

Socrates: That the person is one of three things.

Alcibiades: What are they?

Socrates: Soul or body or both together, the whole.

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: Well then, did we agree that the actual ruler of the body is the person?

Alcibiades: We agreed.

130b

Socrates: Now, does the body itself rule itself?

Alcibiades: Not at all.

Socrates: In fact, we said that it is ruled.

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: In that case this would not be what we are looking for.

Alcibiades: It seems not.

Socrates: Well then, do both together rule the body and is that what the person is?

Alcibiades: Perhaps this is so.

Socrates: It is the least likely of all! For if one element has no share in ruling, I presume there is no way that both together can rule.

Alcibiades: Correct.

130c

Socrates: But since neither the body nor the two together are the person, I think we are left with the conclusion that either he is nothing, or if he is something, the person is nothing else but soul.

Alcibiades: Precisely so.

Socrates: Now, is it necessary to prove to you even more clearly that the soul is the person?

Alcibiades: By Zeus, no! I think that is quite enough.

130d

Socrates: Yes, and if it is proven, not precisely but in good measure, that is sufficient for us. For once we find what we have just passed over because it involves a lot of investigation, we shall then know precisely.

Alcibiades: What was that?

Socrates: It was stated earlier in a general way that we should first investigate the self itself. But now, instead of the self, we have considered what the person himself is. And perhaps this

will suffice, for I presume we would say that nothing more properly belongs to ourselves than the soul?

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: Wouldn't it be right to think of it as follows: you and I are conversing with one another, using words by means of soul, directed to soul?

Alcibiades: Entirely so.

130e

Socrates: So this is what we said a little earlier, that Socrates is talking to Alcibiades using speech, directing the words, as it seems, not to the outward person but to Alcibiades, and he is the soul.

Alcibiades: I think so anyway.

Socrates: So whoever is commanding us to 'know thyself' is calling upon us to know the soul.

Alcibiades: So it seems.

131a

Socrates: So whoever knows anything that belongs to the body has known what belongs to himself, but has not known himself.

Alcibiades: So he has.

Socrates: Then to the extent that he is a doctor, no doctor knows himself, nor to the extent that he is a trainer, does any trainer.

Alcibiades: It seems not.

131b

Socrates: So farmers and other craftsmen fall far short of knowing themselves. For it seems these people, at any rate, do not even know what belongs to themselves. Instead they are further from themselves on account of the skills they possess. For they know what belongs to the body, the things with which

the body is cared for.

Alcibiades: What you say is true.

Socrates: So, if sound-mindedness is knowing thyself, none of them are sound-minded on account of their skill.

Alcibiades: I think not.

Socrates: For that reason, of course, these skills themselves seem to be lowly and not subjects for a good man.

Alcibiades: That is certainly the case.

Socrates: Is it not the case once more, that whoever, for his part, cares for the body, cares for what belongs to himself, but not for himself?

Alcibiades: Very likely.

131c

Socrates: Yes, but whoever cares for money cares neither for himself nor for what belongs to himself, but for something even more remote than what belongs to himself. Does he not?

Alcibiades: I think so.

Socrates: So the money-maker is no longer engaging in what belongs to himself.

Alcibiades: Correct.

Socrates: So, if someone has become the lover of the body of Alcibiades, he has not actually loved Alcibiades but something belonging to Alcibiades.

Alcibiades: What you say is true.

Socrates: But does anyone who loves your soul, love you?

Alcibiades: From this argument it appears that he must.

Socrates: Would not the lover of your body depart and be gone once the bloom of youth had ceased?

Alcibiades: Apparently.

131d

Socrates: Yes, but the lover of your soul will not go away as long as it goes to the better.

Alcibiades: Quite likely.

Socrates: Well then, I am the lover who goes not away but remains with you when your bodily beauty is fading and all of the others have gone.

Alcibiades: You do well, Socrates. May you never leave me.

Socrates: Then you should yearn to be as beautiful as possible.

Alcibiades: I shall yearn for this.

131e

Socrates: So, this is where you stand. There is not, it seems, nor has there been, a lover of Alcibiades, the son of Clinias, save one only, a person worthy of love, Socrates, the son of Sophroniscus and Phaenarete.

Alcibiades: True.

Socrates: Did you not say that my approach to you was just a little early since you would have approached me before then, wishing to find out why I was the only one who was not going away?

Alcibiades: Yes, that is what happened.

132a

Socrates: Well then, this is the reason. I was the only lover of you, the others loved what belongs to you, but what belongs to you is passing its prime while you are beginning to blossom. And now I shall never leave you, unless you are corrupted by the Athenian populace and become ignoble. In fact, this is what I fear most, that you may become a lover of the populace and get corrupted by them, for many good Athenians have suffered

this fate before you. Indeed, the populace ‘descended from the great-hearted Erechtheus’²⁰ has handsome features but you need to see it naked. So be sure to take the care I am speaking of.

Alcibiades: What care?

132b

Socrates: Bless you! Embark upon civic affairs having first exercised and learned what needs to be learned, but not before then. Thus you may proceed in possession of an antidote and nothing terrible will happen to you.

Alcibiades: What you are saying sounds good to me, Socrates, but try to explain in what way we may care for ourselves.

Socrates: Well, to an extent we have reached a conclusion from our previous discussion, for we are fairly well agreed as to what we are. However, we were afraid in case we might get this wrong and unwittingly care for something else and not to ourselves.

Alcibiades: That is it.

132c

Socrates: And after this, of course, we concluded that we should care for the soul and look to that.

Alcibiades: Obviously.

Socrates: While care for our bodies and our money should be handed over to others.

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: So in what way may we know it with the utmost clarity? Since once we know this, it seems we shall also know ourselves. By the gods, do we not understand the well formulated Delphic inscription which we have just mentioned?

Alcibiades: Have you anything in particular in mind when you say this, Socrates?

132d

Socrates: I shall tell you what I suspect that this inscription is saying and what it means to us. Indeed, there are not likely to be numerous examples of this, only the example based upon sight.

Alcibiades: What do you mean by this?

Socrates: Think about this yourself. If it was advising one of our eyes, just as if the eye was a person, and it said 'see thyself', what would we understand by the exhortation? Would it not mean that the eye should look at something in which it would see itself when it looked there?

Alcibiades: Obviously.

132e

Socrates: Well, can we think of anything we might look at and see both the object and ourselves at the same time?

Alcibiades: Yes, obviously, Socrates, when we look at mirrors and the like.

Socrates: That is right. Now, is there anything of this kind present also in the eye with which we are seeing?

Alcibiades: Definitely.

133a

Socrates: So you have noticed that the features of the person looking into the eye appear in the pupil of the person opposite, as though in a mirror, and we actually call the pupil 'a doll'²¹ because it is an image of the person who is looking in.

Alcibiades: What you say is true.

Socrates: Then an eye beholding an eye and looking into the best part of it, the part with which it too is seeing, would see itself in this way.

Alcibiades: Apparently.

Socrates: Yes, and if it looks into any other part of the person, or into anything else except what resembles this part, it will not see itself.

133b

Alcibiades: What you say is true.

Socrates: So if an eye is going to see itself, must it not look into an eye and into the region of the eye where the excellence of the eye happens to reside? And that excellence presumably is sight?

Alcibiades: It is.

Socrates: Now, dear Alcibiades, if the soul too is going to know itself, must it not look into soul, and especially to that region of soul in which the excellence of soul, wisdom, resides, and to anything else that happens to resemble this?

Alcibiades: I think so, Socrates.

133c

Socrates: Can we say that there is any region of soul more divine than this²², the region associated with knowing and being wise?

Alcibiades: We cannot.

Socrates: So this part of the soul is most like a god, and anyone looking to this, having known all that is divine, both god and wisdom, would also come to know himself with certainty in this way.

Alcibiades: So it appears.

Socrates: Well, just as a mirror is clearer than the reflector in the eye and also purer and brighter, does a god, in like manner, happen to be purer and brighter than what is best in our soul?

Alcibiades: So it seems anyway, Socrates.

Socrates: Then in looking to a god we would also make use of that most beautiful reflector for human purposes, in furthering the excellence of the soul, and in this way we would certainly see and know our own selves.

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Did we agree that to ‘know thyself’ is sound-mindedness?

Alcibiades: Definitely.

Socrates: In that case, without knowing ourselves or being sound-minded, would we be able to know what belongs to us, be it bad or good?

Alcibiades: How could that actually happen, Socrates?

133d

Socrates: Yes, to you it probably seems impossible to know that what belongs to Alcibiades is his, without knowing Alcibiades.

Alcibiades: Of course it is impossible, by Zeus.

Socrates: Then neither can we know that what belongs to us is ours, unless we know ourselves.

Alcibiades: How could we?

Socrates: So if we do not know what belongs to us, we do not know what belongs to our belongings either, do we?

Alcibiades: Apparently not.

133e

Socrates: So we were not entirely correct when we agreed earlier that there are people who do not know themselves and yet know what belongs to themselves, and others who do not even know what belongs to their belongings. For it seems that it is one person and a single skill that beholds himself, what belongs to himself, and what belongs to the belongings of himself.

Alcibiades: Very likely.

Socrates: But whoever is ignorant of what belongs to himself would also, on the same basis, be ignorant of what belongs to others, I suppose.

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: And if he is ignorant of what belongs to others, he will also be ignorant of what belongs to cities.

Alcibiades: He must.

Socrates: Then a man like this could never become a statesman.

Alcibiades: Of course not.

Socrates: Nor run a household either.

Alcibiades: Of course not.

134a

Socrates: Nor will he even know what he is doing.

Alcibiades: No, not at all.

Socrates: But will not a person who does not know fall into error?

Alcibiades: Definitely.

Socrates: And will not a person who falls into error act badly, both in private and public affairs?

Alcibiades: How could he avoid it?

Socrates: And in acting badly will he not be wretched?

Alcibiades: Very much so.

Socrates: What about the people he acts for?

Alcibiades: They will be wretched too.

Socrates: So a person would not be able to be happy unless he were sound-minded and good.

Alcibiades: He would not.

134b

Socrates: So the bad people are wretched.

Alcibiades: Very much so.

Socrates: Then the man who has become rich is not yet free from wretchedness, but the soundminded man is.

Alcibiades: Apparently.

Socrates: So, Alcibiades, the cities need neither walls nor triremes nor dockyards if they wish to be happy, neither do they need numbers or size, without excellence.

Alcibiades: Indeed not.

134c

Socrates: In that case, if you do intend to engage in civic affairs properly and nobly, you must bestow excellence upon the citizens.

Alcibiades: There is not another way.

Socrates: But could anyone bestow what he does not possess?

Alcibiades: No, how could he?

Socrates: Then you should first acquire excellence yourself, and so should anyone else who is about to rule and attend to the city and to its affairs, and not just to himself and to his own affairs in private.

Alcibiades: What you say is true.

Socrates: Then you should make justice and sound-mindedness available, rather than the power or the authority for yourself or the city to do as they please.

Alcibiades: So it appears.

134d

Socrates: And by acting in a just and sound-minded way, both you and the city will be acting in a manner beloved of God.

Alcibiades: Quite likely.

Socrates: And as we said before, you will act whilst looking to what is divine and bright.

Alcibiades: So it appears.

Socrates: And, indeed, once you look there you will behold and come to know yourselves, and also the goods that are your own.

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: In that case, will you not act rightly and well?

Alcibiades: Yes.

134e

Socrates: Well then, if you act in this way, I am prepared to guarantee that you simply must be happy.

Alcibiades: You are indeed a secure guarantor.

Socrates: But if you act unjustly, looking to what is godless and dark, you will in all likelihood act in a manner resembling these because of your ignorance of yourselves.

Alcibiades: So it seems.

135a

Socrates: Yes, my dear Alcibiades, for what is likely to happen to someone in private or in public who has power to act as he pleases, but is lacking in intelligence? Take, for instance, a sick person with the power to do what he wishes but without having any medical intelligence, and who is so tyrannical that no one dares rebuke him. What will the outcome be? Is it not likely that his body will be ruined?

Alcibiades: What you say is true.

Socrates: And in a ship, if someone has power to do what seems best, but is devoid of intelligence and excellence in helmsmanship, do you see what would happen to him and to his fellow sailors?

Alcibiades: I think they would all perish.

135b

Socrates: And similarly, in a city and in every position of power and authority, does not bad action follow once excellence is forsaken?

Alcibiades: It must.

Socrates: So if there is to be happiness, excellent Alcibiades, it is not tyranny that must be provided either for yourself or the city, but excellence.

Alcibiades: What you say is true.

Socrates: But before they possess excellence it is better, not just for a child but also for a man, to be ruled by someone better rather than exercising rule.

Alcibiades: So it appears.

Socrates: And is not the better also more noble?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And is the more noble, more fitting?

135c

Alcibiades: What else could it be?

Socrates: So it is fitting that someone bad be a slave, since it is better.

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Then badness befits a slave.

Alcibiades: Apparently.

Socrates: But excellence befits the free.

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: In that case, my friend, should we not flee from the slavish spirit?

Alcibiades: More than anything, Socrates.

Socrates: And are you now aware of your own condition? Does this befit a free man or not?

Alcibiades: I think that I am very well aware of it.

Socrates: Well, do you know how to escape this present predicament of yours? Let us not name it in the case of a noble man.

135d

Alcibiades: I do indeed.

Socrates: How?

Alcibiades: If it be your will, Socrates.

Socrates: That is not the right thing to say, Alcibiades.

Alcibiades: What should I say?

Socrates: If God wills it.

Alcibiades: Those are my words then. And as well as this, I also declare that we are likely to exchange roles, Socrates, so that I take yours and you take mine. Indeed, from this day forth, there is no alternative but that I shall follow you and you will be followed by me.

135e

Socrates: How noble! So my love will turn out to be just like a stork²³ if it, in turn, will now be cared for by the winged love it hatched within you.

Alcibiades: Well, that is how matters stand, and I shall begin henceforth to care for justice.

Socrates: And it is my wish that you may accomplish your objective. Yet, I have a foreboding, not from any lack of faith in your nature, but beholding the might of the city, I fear that it may overpower both me and you.

NOTES

1. Pericles was the most famous Athenian politician and orator of the mid 5th century.
2. Two early kings of the vast Persian (Achaemenid) Empire.
3. Flute-playing distorts the facial features in a comic manner. According to legend, Athena threw the instrument away, having seen a reflection of her altered face.
4. This is essentially an oath to Zeus, since he was regarded as the god of friendship.
5. Euripides, Hippolytus 350-353.
6. A tiny Aegean island off the coast of Thessaly, which serves as a contrast to the much larger city of Athens.
7. Pythoclides of Ceos and Damon of Athens were musicians and musicologists. Anaxagoras of Clazomenae was a natural philosopher. They all taught in Athens in the 5th century.
8. Pythodorus and Callias were prominent Athenian politicians. Zeno of Elea was a philosopher and student of Parmenides. Plato, Parmenides 126e-128e.
9. A politician and figure of fun in Athens about whom little else is known.
10. According to legend, Eurysaces was the son of the hero Ajax. He was celebrated in Athens.
11. Socrates' father, Sophroniscus, was a sculptor. Ancient sculptors regarded Daedalus as the father of their trade.
12. Aeacus was a legendary king of Aegina, a small island in the Saronic Gulf.
13. This line is thought to have come from one of the lost plays of Plato the comic poet.
14. Zoroaster, also known as Zarathustra, was the founder of Zoroastrianism, which became the official religion of the Achaemenid Empire in Persia.
15. Dinomache was Alcibiades' mother.
16. The Attic acre was equivalent to 874 square metres.
17. Leotyichides, Archidamus and Agis were all kings of Sparta.

18. A 'span' is the distance from thumb to little finger of the outstretched palm; a cubit is the distance from the elbow to the end of the little finger.

19. *Odyssey* ii.365.

20. A Homeric phrase used to describe Athenians. *Iliad* ii.547.

21. In addition to 'pupil', the Greek word *korē* and the Latin word *pupilla* both also meant 'little girl' or 'doll'.

22. The passage from 133c8-17 is not in the main manuscripts (B & T).

23. This analogy is based upon the story that storks, in old age, were fed by younger birds which they had previously hatched and reared.

Alcibiades II

ΑΛΚΙΒΙΑΔΗΣ ΙΙ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

ALCIBIADES a famous and notorious politician and general

scene: on the way to an unknown temple

138a

Socrates: Alcibiades, are you on your way to pray to the god?

Alcibiades: Certainly, Socrates.

Socrates: I must say that you look sullen and downcast as if you were preoccupied with something.

Alcibiades: And what might preoccupy someone, Socrates?

138b

Socrates: What I regard as the greatest preoccupation, Alcibiades. Come on, by Zeus, don't you think that the gods to whom we pray, in public and private, sometimes grant our requests and sometimes do not, and favour some people and not others?

Alcibiades: Entirely so.

Socrates: Don't you think it requires great foresight to avoid praying unwittingly for great evils, thinking them to be good when the gods happen to be disposed to grant whatever one happens to pray for? Just as Oedipus¹ is said to have prayed impetuously that his sons would divide their inheritance by the sword, and although it was open to him to pray for some means of averting the evils he was facing, he called down further curses in addition. Consequently, all these developments came to pass, and from these came many more terrible events which we need not recount in detail.

Alcibiades: But, Socrates, you have described a man who was mad, for who do you think would dare utter such prayers whilst sane?

Socrates: And do you think being mad is the opposite of being wise?

Alcibiades: I certainly do.

138d

Socrates: And do you think some people are unwise while others are wise?

Alcibiades: They are indeed.

Socrates: Come on then, let's consider who precisely these people are. We have agreed that there are the unwise and the wise, and others who are mad.

Alcibiades: Yes, we have agreed.

Socrates: And what's more, there are some who are healthy?

Alcibiades: There are.

Socrates: Aren't there others who are unhealthy?

139a

Alcibiades: Certainly.

Socrates: And they are not the same?

Alcibiades: Indeed not.

Socrates: Now, are there any others who are in neither of these conditions?

Alcibiades: Of course not.

Socrates: For it is necessary that a person be either ill or not ill.

Alcibiades: I think so.

Socrates: Well then, when it comes to wisdom and unwisdom, do you hold the same view?

Alcibiades: How do you mean?

Socrates: Do you think it is only possible to be wise or unwise, or is there a third condition in between which makes a person neither wise nor unwise?

139b

Alcibiades: No, there is not.

Socrates: So, it is necessary to be in one or the other of these conditions.

Alcibiades: So it seems to me, at any rate.

Socrates: Don't you remember agreeing that madness is opposite to wisdom?

Alcibiades: I do.

Socrates: And also that there is no third condition in between which makes a person neither wise nor unwise?

Alcibiades: Yes, I agreed.

Socrates: Now, can there possibly be two opposites of one thing?

Alcibiades: Not at all.

Socrates: So it seems that unwisdom and madness are the same.

139c

Alcibiades: Apparently.

Socrates: So, we would be right to say that all unwise people are mad, Alcibiades, and this applies not just to any of your peers who happen to be unwise, as some are, but even to your elders. Indeed, by Zeus, don't you think that in our city the wise are few while most people are unwise, and these people you refer to as mad?

Alcibiades: I do.

139d

Socrates: Now, do you think we could live happily as fellow citizens alongside so many mad people for so long without paying the penalty of being assailed or assaulted and suffering under the familiar behaviour of mad people? No, look for yourself, blessed man, this is not the situation we find ourselves in.

Alcibiades: No, how could it be, Socrates? It looks as if the situation is not as I had thought.

Socrates: I don't think so either. But consider the matter carefully in another way.

Alcibiades: What way do you mean?

Socrates: I shall tell you. We understand that some people are ill, do we not?

Alcibiades: We certainly do.

139e

Socrates: Now, do you think that a sick person necessarily has gout or fever or eye inflammation, or don't you think that someone suffering from none of these may be sick with some other illness? For there are presumably many illnesses and not just these three.

Alcibiades: I agree.

Socrates: Now, do you think that every eye inflammation is a disease?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: And is every disease an eye inflammation?

Alcibiades: I certainly don't think so, although I am at a loss as to what I am saying.

140a

Socrates: But if you give me your attention, the two of us, seeking together, may find what we are looking for.

Alcibiades: Well, I am paying attention, Socrates, to the best of my ability.

140b

Socrates: Did we not agree that although every eye inflammation is a disease, not every disease is an eye inflammation? contrast, not all who are ill have fever or gout or an eye inflammation, I presume. Rather, although everything of this sort is a disease, according to those whom we call physicians they differ in the effect they have. For they are not all alike, nor do they operate in like manner, but each acts in accordance with its own capacity even though they are all diseases. In the same way, we understand some people to be artisans, do we not?

Alcibiades: We certainly do.

140c

Socrates: Aren't there cobblers and carpenters and sculptors, and a whole host of others whom we need not mention individually? They have their own particular parts of craftsmanship, and they are all craftsmen, but they are not all carpenters or cobblers or sculptors, even though all of them are craftsmen.

Alcibiades: Indeed not.

Socrates: Well, people have also been allocated unwisdom in this way too. Some who possess the largest portion of this we refer to as mad, while those who have the least portion are called stupid, although those who prefer to use nice-sounding names refer to them as great d hearted or simple, or again as innocent, inexperienced or senseless. And you will, on investigation, discover many other names, though these are all unwisdom, but the names differ, just as it was evident to us that a skill differs from a skill and a disease from a disease. Or how does it seem to you?

Alcibiades: As you say.

Socrates: Then we should go back over the argument again from this point. For it was said, presumably, at the outset that it was necessary to consider who precisely the wise and the unwise people are, since we agreed that there are such people. Did we not?

Alcibiades: Yes, this was agreed.

140e

Socrates: Now, do you understand the wise to be those who know what to do and what to say?

Alcibiades: I do.

Socrates: Who then are the unwise? Are they the people who know neither of these?

Alcibiades: They are.

Socrates: Will those who do not know either of these unwittingly do and say things they shouldn't?

Alcibiades: Apparently.

141a

Socrates: I spoke of these people, Alcibiades, and I said that Oedipus was an example. But nowadays you will still find many such people, not acting in anger as Oedipus did, nor believing that they are praying for bad things, but for good things. That man neither prayed so nor thought so, but there are others who are in the opposite predicament. For I imagine that if the god, to whom you are on your way, were to make himself manifest to you first, before you prayed for anything, and were to ask you if you would be content with becoming tyrant of the city of Athens, and you were to regard this as mean and insignificant, he might then add tyranny over all the Greeks. But what if he saw that this still seemed inadequate unless he also promised all of Europe, and he promised not only that, but the recognition

by everyone, there and then, if you so desired, that Alcibiades, the son of Clinias, is their tyrant? I think you would depart in delight as though you had obtained the greatest possible goods.

Alcibiades: And so, I believe, Socrates, would anyone else if advantages of this sort were to come their way.

141c

Socrates: And yet you would have no desire to trade your own life even for the territory and tyranny of all the Greeks and non-Greeks.

Alcibiades: I think not. How could I when I'm not going to make any use of these advantages?

Socrates: And what if you were going to use them, but harmfully and badly? You would have no such desire under these circumstances either, would you?

Alcibiades: Indeed not.

141d

Socrates: So, you see that it is not safe either to unthinkingly accept what is given, or to pray for some outcome if one is going to be harmed by this or lose one's life entirely. We could speak of so many people who, at some stage, set their hearts upon tyranny and made it their business to attain it, as if they were achieving something good, but whose life was then lost through conspiracies because of the tyranny. And I presume you are not unaware of certain events of today or yesterday, when Archelaus, the tyrant of Macedon, had a lover who loved tyranny just as much as Archelaus loved him, and who killed his lover, Archelaus, so as to become tyrant and a happy man. But having held the role of tyrant for three or four days, he in turn was the victim of a plot by some others and was slain. You also see examples among our own citizens which we have not heard from other sources. Indeed, we know first-hand of those who set their hearts upon military command, but having acquired

this, some still remain exiles from this city while others have lost their lives. But even those who seem to have done best have faced many dangers and terrors, not just in their military command, but when they returned to their own homeplace where they have been constantly besieged by informers, just as much as they were by the enemy. As a result, some of them prayed to have no military command rather than being a general. Now, if these dangers and troubles were of some advantage, this might make sense, but the situation is the very opposite. And you will also find that the situation is the same in relation to offspring. Some people have prayed that children might be born to them, but once they have been born, the parents had been subjected to the greatest misfortunes and tribulations. For some whose children were degenerate in the extreme have spent their entire lives in tribulation, while others had good children who met with disaster. So they were deprived of their children, and were thus subjected to just as much bad luck as the others, and wished that no children had ever been born to them. But, nevertheless, although these people and many others like them are so very plain to be seen, it is hard to find anyone who would refuse to accept what is given, or who would stop praying when the object of their prayers was about to be attained. But most people would not refuse the grant of a tyranny, or of military command, or lots of other things whose possession would do them more harm than good. They would, rather, pray for those things if they did not already have them. But a little later they sometimes recant, taking back their prayers for whatever they initially prayed for. So, I question whether we humans are blaming the gods without reason, when we ourselves, by our own recklessness and unwisdom, you might say, incur more sorrows than fate decreed. It is quite likely then, Alcibiades, that a certain poet was wise, despite having stupid friends whom he saw working and praying for things that were not good, although they

thought they were. He uttered a prayer in common, on all their behalf, saying: King Zeus, give us what is good whether we pray for it or not, Avert what is bad for us even if we pray for it. Now, I believe the poet is making a good, sound point here, but if you have any views to the contrary, please don't keep them quiet.

143b

Alcibiades: It is difficult, Socrates, to contradict a good point. But this much I am aware of: just how much evil is caused to humanity by ignorance, when it seems we forget ourselves because of this, and enact, or, worst of all, pray to be granted the greatest evils. Now, this is something no one believes about themselves. Each believes, rather, that they are well are not speaking correctly when we criticise ignorance in this offhand way if we don't also mention what the ignorance is of, and that it is good for some people in certain situations, just as it is bad for those others.

Alcibiades: How do you mean? Is there anything at all that it is better for anyone at all, in any situation, to have ignorance of rather than knowledge?

Socrates: Well, I for one think so, don't you?

Alcibiades: By Zeus, I do not.

143d

Socrates: But surely I am not to form this unfavourable view of you, that you would wish to behave towards your own mother just as Orestes⁴ and Alcmaeon did, and some others too who behaved in the same way towards their own mothers.

Alcibiades: Mind what you say, by Zeus, Socrates.

Socrates: But, Alcibiades, it is not the person who says that you would not wish to behave like this whom you should bid to mind what he says, but rather anyone who says the opposite. For the deed seems so very awful to you that it should not even be mentioned in such a casual manner. But do you think that

Orestes, if he happened to be wise and had known what was best for himself to do, would have dared to behave in such a manner?

Alcibiades: Indeed not.

143e

Socrates: Nor, I believe, would anyone else.

Socrates: So, ignorance of what is best and to ignore what is best are, it seems, bad?

Alcibiades: I think so.

Socrates: Both for that person and all others?

Alcibiades: I agree.

144a

Socrates: Well, let's consider the following case. What if it were suddenly to occur to you that it was a good idea to go to the door of Pericles⁵, your own guardian and friend, carrying a dagger, and ask if he was at home with the intention of killing that man himself and no one else, and they told you that he was at home? Now, I am not saying that you would actually wish to do any of this, unless you were ever to get an idea which could, of course, easily occur to someone who is ignorant of what is best, thinking that what is actually worst is, at the time, best. Or don't you think so?

Alcibiades: Entirely so.

144b

Socrates: Now, if you arrived, entered, and saw that man, but did not recognise him and thought he was someone else, would you still dare to kill him?

Alcibiades: No, by Zeus, I should think not.

Socrates: For the person you wished to kill was presumably that man and not some random person. Is this so?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Well, if you were to make the attempt many times, always failing to recognise Pericles when you were about to do the deed, you would never lay a hand on him.

Alcibiades: Indeed not.

Socrates: What about this? Do you think Orestes would ever have laid hands upon his mother if he, in like manner, had failed to recognise her?

144c

Alcibiades: No, I don't think so.

Socrates: For he did not, presumably, intend to kill any random woman, or the mother of anyone at all, but only his own mother.

Alcibiades: This is so.

Socrates: So, it is better for those with such dispositions, possessed of such intentions, to be ignorant of these things.

Alcibiades: So it appears.

Socrates: Do you see that for some people, in some situations, there are things which it is good to be ignorant of. It is not bad, as you thought previously.

Alcibiades: So it seems.

Socrates: Yet if you care to consider the consequence of this, you are likely to think it most strange.

144d

Alcibiades: What precisely, Socrates?

Socrates: That it is likely, in a sense, that the acquisition of other kinds of knowledge, if they are acquired without knowledge of what is best, are seldom of benefit, and in most cases do harm to the possessor. Think of it this way. Don't you

think it necessary that whenever we are about to do or say anything, we must actually know about or think that we know about whatever it is we are going to say or do?

144e

Alcibiades: I think so.

145a

Socrates: Don't the rhetoricians, for example, either know how to advise us, or think they know how to advise us from time to time, sometimes about war and peace, sometimes about the construction of walls or the equipping of harbours. In short, whatever the city does in its internal or external dealings is all done on the advice of the rhetoricians.

Alcibiades: True.

Socrates: See what follows.

Alcibiades: If I am able.

Socrates: You surely refer to people as wise and unwise?

Alcibiades: I do.

Socrates: Don't you call most people unwise and a few people wise?

Alcibiades: Quite so.

Socrates: In both cases, don't you look to some criterion?

Alcibiades: Yes.

145b

Socrates: Now, do you call someone wise who knows how to give such advice without knowing whether it is best or when it is best?

Alcibiades: Of course not.

Socrates: Nor, I believe, is someone who knows about warfare itself without knowing when it is best and for how long a time it

is best. Is this so?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: Nor again is someone who knows how to kill another, or take away his money, or make him an exile from his homeland without knowing when this is best and to whom this is best done?

Alcibiades: Indeed not.

145c

Socrates: Then there is the person who knows about things of this sort and also has knowledge of what is best, which is presumably the same as knowledge of what is beneficial. Is this so?

Alcibiades: Yes.

Socrates: This person we shall call wise, and a competent adviser both to the city and to himself, while someone who is not like this we shall call the opposite of these. What do you think?

145d

Alcibiades: I agree. other sport, or anything else of that sort that we know by means of a skill? What do you call someone who knows what is done better by that particular skill? In the case of the skill of horse riding, isn't he a horse rider?

Alcibiades: I agree.

Socrates: And in the case of the skill of boxing, I imagine, he is a boxer, and in the case of the skill of flute playing, he is a flute player, and the same holds for the other skills. Or do you think they are somehow different?

Alcibiades: No, that's it.

145e

Socrates: Now, do you think it is necessarily the case that someone who is knowledgeable about any of these is also a wise man, or shall we maintain that much more is required?

Alcibiades: Much more, by Zeus.

146a

Socrates: Suppose there was a state consisting of good archers and flute players, athletes too, and other skilled people, mixed in with the people we mentioned earlier who know about warfare itself and about slaughter itself, and with rhetoricians puffed up with political conceit, all of whom were devoid of the knowledge of what is best and knew not when and towards whom it was better to employ their particular skills. What kind of a state do you think that would be?

Alcibiades: A bad one, Socrates, in my view.

146b

Socrates: You would indeed say so, I believe, once you saw each of them competing to allocate influence in civic affairs to the part 'wherein he happens to do best'. And I mean what is best by the standard of his particular skill, which is far wide of the mark of what is best for the city and for himself, since I believe he puts his faith in opinion devoid of reason. And this being the case, wouldn't we be right to say that we should expect such a state to be full of upheaval and lawlessness?

Alcibiades: Right indeed, by Zeus.

Socrates: Didn't we believe it necessary that we either think that we know about, or actually know about, whatever we are just about to do or say?

Alcibiades: We did.

146c

Socrates: What if someone does what he knows about, or thinks he knows about, and, in addition, knows what is beneficial? Won't we maintain that he is an asset to the city and to himself?

Alcibiades: Of course.

Socrates: But I imagine under the opposite circumstances, he is an asset neither to the city nor to himself.

Alcibiades: Indeed not.

Socrates: Now then, do you still hold the same view as before or is it somehow different?

Alcibiades: No, it is the same.

Socrates: Did you say that you refer to most people as unwise and to a few as wise?

Alcibiades: I did.

Socrates: And now we are saying once more that most people are far wide of the mark of what is best because, I believe, they put their faith in opinion devoid of reason.

146d

Alcibiades: So we say.

Socrates: So, it is to the advantage of most people neither to know, nor think that they know, if they are going to be emboldened to engage in certain actions they are knowledgeable about, or think they are knowledgeable about, when such actions will, in general, be more harmful than beneficial.

Alcibiades: Very true.

146e

Socrates: Do you see then that I was apparently right when I said that it is likely that the acquisition of various kinds of knowledge – if someone acquires them without acquiring the knowledge of what is best – is seldom of benefit and for the most part does harm to their possessor?

Alcibiades: Well, if I didn't think so at the time, I do now, Socrates.

147a

Socrates: It is necessary, then, for a city or a soul to cleave to this knowledge, exactly as a sick person cleaves to a physician, or someone who is going to sail in safety cleaves to a helmsman. For in the absence of this knowledge, the more brightly the breeze of chance wafts them, either towards the acquisition of wealth or physical strength, or anything else of that sort, the greater the error, it seems, that naturally arises from these things. And someone who has acquired a reputation for being very learned or highly skilled, while being bereft of this knowledge and led by one or other of the various kinds of knowledge, will rightly end up in very stormy waters indeed, will he not, since he is, I believe, embarking upon the ocean without a helmsman, with but a short span of life to run? And so, the words of the poet seem to me to apply to this case, where he accuses someone, saying, “He knows many works, but he knows them all badly.”⁷

Alcibiades: But why exactly is the line from the poet applicable, Socrates? Indeed, it does not seem at all relevant to me.

147c

Socrates: And yet it is highly relevant, but this poet speaks in riddles, best of men, like almost all poets. For all poetry naturally uses riddles, and it is not just anyone who can understand. And in addition to this natural tendency, whenever it takes hold of a possessive person who is reluctant to display his own wisdom to us and wishes to conceal it as much as possible, it proves exceedingly difficult to understand what each of them has in mind. For you surely don’t think that Homer, the most divine and the wisest of poets, was unaware that it is not possible to ‘know badly’. For he was the one who said that Margites, although he knew many things, knew them all badly. But he was, I believe, speaking in riddles, and used ‘badly’ in place of ‘bad’, and ‘knew’ in place of ‘to know’. Now, if we put this together, ignoring the metre, what he means turns

out to be that “he knew many works, but it was bad for him to know all these”. Of course, if it was indeed bad for him to know a great deal, he proves to be a degenerate person if we are to believe our previous arguments.

147e

Alcibiades: And I think we should, Socrates. Yes, if I were to have difficulty in accepting these arguments, it would be hard for me to be convinced by any arguments.

Socrates: And you are right to think so.

Alcibiades: But I am having second thoughts about this.

148a

Socrates: But come on, by Zeus, you surely see the nature and extent of the difficulty in which, I believe, you have shared. You are incessantly changing your position this way and that, and whatever seems certain to you is forgotten and you no longer hold that view at all. And even now, if the god to whom you are presently proceeding were to make himself manifest and ask you, before you had uttered a single prayer, if it would be enough for you to have any of those things that were mentioned at the outset, or whether he should leave you to pray just by yourself, which do you think would yield the best outcome – accepting what the god offers, or praying on your own?

148b

Alcibiades: But by the gods, Socrates, I would not be able to respond to you offhand. I believe, rather, that your question is impetuous, and I believe that, in truth, this requires a great deal of care lest a person unwittingly prays for what is bad for himself thinking it to be good, then a little later, as you said, he recants and takes back all the prayers he first uttered.

Socrates: Didn't that poet I mentioned at the beginning of our discussion know better than us ^{148c} Well the Spartans too,

Alcibiades, either in admiration for this poet or because they had worked it out for themselves, frequently utter a similar prayer in private and in public, calling upon the gods to grant them the beautiful and the good. No one would ever hear them praying for more than this. Consequently, to this very day they are no less fortunate than any other people. And so, even if everything does not turn out fortunately for them, it is not because of this prayer of theirs. It is up to the gods, I believe, either to grant whatever someone happens to pray for, or the very opposite of this. And I would like to tell you another story that I once heard from one of our elders. A conflict had arisen between the Athenians and the Spartans, but whenever there was a battle by sea or by land, it always turned out that our city met with misfortune and was unable ever to prevail. Now, the Athenians, being troubled by this development and being at a loss to find any means of averting their ongoing difficulties, decided among themselves that the best course was to send a question to Ammon, and enquire further as to why exactly the gods grant victory to the Spartans rather than to themselves. “We”, they said, “bring them more sacrifices than the rest of the Greeks, more perfect too, and like no other peoples we have embellished their temples with offerings, and have bestowed expensive, solemn processions upon the gods every single year, and have spent more money than all other Greek peoples put together. None of these matters is a concern to the Spartans, and their attitude towards the gods is so demeaning that they consistently sacrifice defective animals, and, in general, their respect falls considerably short of ours even though they have accumulated just as much wealth as our city.” Once they had said all this and asked what they needed to do to find deliverance from their present evils, the prophet called them to him and gave this response, and nothing more, for it was obviously all the god would allow. “Athenians,” said he, “the god Ammon says ‘I prefer the reverent utterance of the

Spartans to all the sacrifices of the Greeks.” This is as much as he said, and not one word further. Now, I think that the reverent utterance that the god refers to is nothing other than their prayer, for it really is very different from the prayers of others. As for the rest of the Greeks, some present the gods with golden horned oxen, while others bestow offerings, praying for whatever occurs to them to pray for, be it good or be it bad. And as they utter their irreverent words, the gods hear them but refuse to accept these expensive processions and sacrifices. But I believe that great vigilance is required, and deliberation too, as to what precisely should be said and what should not. And in Homer you will also find other accounts similar to these. For he says that the Trojans, setting up their camp: They accomplished likewise full sacrifices before the Immortals, and the winds wafted the savour aloft from the plain to the heavens in its fragrance; and yet the blessed gods took no part of it. They would not; so hateful to them was sacred Ilion, and Priam, and the city of Priam of the strong ash spear. And so it was not to their advantage to offer sacrifices and pay tribute in vain with their gifts since they were hated by the gods. For I don’t think the way of the gods is such that they are influenced by gifts, like some base profiteer. And our argument is indeed absurd if we claim to be superior to the Spartans in this respect. For it would surely be terrible if the gods were looking at our sacrifices and gifts rather than the soul, and whether any happens to be holy and just. I believe that they look at this much more than at those costly processions and sacrifices that a city or an individual may well offer on an annual basis, even though they have done great wrong to the gods or their fellow man. But the gods, since they are not corrupt, despise all these gifts, as the gods and the prophet of the gods declare. And so it is likely that in the eyes of the gods and of reasonable people, justice and wisdom are especially honoured, and the wise and the just people are none other than those who know what to do and

what to say, both to gods and humans. But I would also like to find out what you think about these matters.

Alcibiades: Well, Socrates, my view does not differ from yours or from the god's, for it would not be reasonable for me to cast my vote against the god.

150c

Socrates: Don't you remember saying that you were in great perplexity lest you might unwittingly pray for evils, thinking them to be good?

Alcibiades: I do.

150d

Socrates: You now see how unsafe it is for you to go to the god in prayer, in case it turns out that he, hearing your irreverent words, declines to accept this sacrifice, and you perhaps reap something else in addition. So I think it best that you keep quiet, for I don't think you are willing to use the Spartan prayer due to your great-heartedness, which is our nicest word for folly. So it is necessary to wait until one has learned how one should behave towards gods and men.

Alcibiades: How long will that take, Socrates, and who will be my educator? I think I would be pleased to see who that person is.

150e

Socrates: The one who cares about you, but it seems to me that just as Homer recounts that Athena removed the mist from the eyes of Diomedes, That he might well recognise both God and man so you too should first have the mist that currently envelops your soul removed. Only then will you acquire the ability to recognise both good and evil. For at the moment I don't think you're able to do this.

Alcibiades: Let him remove the mist or whatever else he wishes to call it. For whoever this person may be, I am prepared to

comply, without evasion, with anything he commands, provided I am going to become better.

Socrates: And he too is wonderfully well disposed towards you.

151a

Alcibiades: Well, I think it best to defer the sacrifice until then.

Socrates: And you are right to think so, for it is safer than taking a risk when there is such a danger.

151b

Alcibiades: What about this Socrates? I shall crown you with this garland, since I believe you have advised me so well, and later, when I behold the arrival of that day, we shall bestow garlands and all other traditional gifts upon the gods. And if they are willing, that day will not be long in coming.

151c

Socrates: And I shall accept this too, and I gladly anticipate any other gifts you may give me. And just as Euripides⁶ makes Creon say, upon seeing Tiresias wearing garlands and hearing that he obtained them from the enemy as offerings because of his skill, I take your garlands of victory as a good omen, For we are tossed upon the waves as you well know. so too do I take this opinion of yours as an omen. For I think that I too am tossed upon the waves, just as much as Creon, and I would like to win a victory over your lovers.

NOTES

1. The reference here is to an epic poem, *The Thebans*. The result of Oedipus's prayer was that his sons killed each other.
2. *Odyssey* i.32-34.
3. A modified epigram, X.108, from the *Palatine Anthology*.
4. Orestes and Alcmaeon, according to legend, both committed matricide to avenge the deaths of their fathers.
5. After the death of Alcibiades' father at the battle of Coronea, Pericles and his brother Ariphon became the guardians of Alcibiades.
6. Euripides, *Antiope*, Fragment 183, Nauck.
7. The line quoted here is from *Margites*, Fragment 3, Allen. In antiquity, this work was erroneously believed to have been by Homer.
8. Ammon was an Egyptian god who was worshipped in Greece. He had important shrines in Thebes, Sparta, and an important oracle at Siwa in the Libyan desert. In Greece, Ammon was sometimes associated with Zeus.
9. *Iliad*, viii.548-552, Lattimore.
10. *Iliad*, v.128.
11. Euripides, *Phoenicians* 858-859.

Apology

ΑΠΟΛΟΓΙΑ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES *of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus*

MELETUS *Socrates' prosecutor*

scene: a court in or near the Athenian Agora

SOCRATES SPEAKING AT HIS TRIAL IN 399

17a

How you, men of Athens¹, have been affected by my accusers, I do not know. As for me, they spoke so persuasively that they almost made me forget myself, and yet they have hardly spoken one word of truth. But of the many lies they told, there was one that amazed me more than any, when they ^{17b} said that you must be on your guard lest you be deceived by me because I am a formidable speaker. The fact that they were not ashamed of being immediately refuted by me once I actually show myself to be no formidable speaker at all, this I thought utterly disgraceful of them, unless they are calling the person who speaks the truth a formidable speaker. For if that is what they mean, I would accept that I am an orator, but not after their fashion. These men, as I say, have said little or ^{17c} nothing that is true, but from me you shall hear the complete truth, without ornate speeches, beautifully adorned in every word and phrase, like the ones you heard from my accusers. No, men of Athens, by Zeus, you shall hear me say whatever occurs to me to say, in a random manner, and none of you should expect anything else since I am convinced of the justice of what I am saying. For it certainly would not be appropriate, at my age, to appear before you, men of Athens, with ^{17d} contrived arguments like some juvenile orator. What is more, men of Athens, I ask this of you, indeed I implore you, neither to be surprised nor to cause a commotion if you hear me defending myself using the same arguments I am also accustomed to using at the tables in the

Agora, where so many of you have heard me, and elsewhere too. For the fact of the matter is that I am appearing before the court now, for the first time, at seventy years of age, so the language of the place is simply foreign to me. Now, if in fact I happened to be a foreigner, you would surely have forgiven me ^{18a} if I spoke in my own dialect and in the way I had been brought up to speak. And so I am now making a request of you, a just request in my view, that for better or worse you accept my manner of speaking, and consider and apply your minds to this alone: if what I am saying is just, or not. For this is the very excellence of a judge, while the excellence of an orator is to speak the truth. Now, it is only right that I first defend myself, men of Athens, against the first false accusations laid against me and my first accusers, and then deal with the later ones and the later accusers. For many of my accusers came to you a long time ago, many years ago, speaking not a word of truth, and I am more afraid of these accusers than of Anytus² and his associates, although they too are formidable. But these are more formidable people, who got control of most of you, gentlemen, in childhood, gaining your trust and making accusations against me with no regard for the truth: that there is this Socrates, a wise man, who is preoccupied with the heavens above, has investigated everything beneath the earth, and who makes the weaker argument stronger.

^{18c}

The people, men of Athens, who put this story about are my most formidable accusers, since those who hear this tend to believe that whoever investigates such matters does not believe in the gods either. What is more, these accusers are numerous, and they have been making their accusations for a long time now; indeed, they were speaking to you at an age when you were most easily convinced – some of you were just children or youths – making unanswered accusations to which no defence was offered. But what is most unreasonable of all is that it is not

even possible to be sure of their names and state them, unless one of them happens to be a certain ^{18d} comic poet. Yet those who convinced you by recourse to malice and slander, or those who convinced others too when they themselves had been convinced, all these people present a formidable challenge. For it is impossible to bring them here or to cross-examine any of them. So I must simply fight with shadows in my own defence, and conduct a cross-examination to which no one responds. So you really should accept, as I say, that there have been two groups of accusers – those who accused me recently, and the earlier ones whom I am now describing. And please accept that ^{18e} I must defend myself against these first. For these were the first accusers you heard, and you heard them for longer than my recent accusers. So be it. I must make a defence then, men of Athens, and attempt in such a short time to undo a slander you have picked up over many years. Now, this is ^{19a} the outcome I would prefer if it were somehow better for you and for me, and I would like to succeed in my defence, but I think this is difficult, and the sort of task it is has not entirely escaped my notice. In any case, let this unfold in whatever way the god pleases, yet the law must be obeyed so I must present a defence. What, in fact, is the allegation that has given rise to this slander against me? Presumably the ^{19b} one Meletus relied upon when he brought this charge against me. Let us take up this question, from the beginning. Well, when the slanderers slandered me, what did they say? Well, I should read out their charge as if they were the accusers. “Socrates acts unjustly and is excessively curious, investigating things beneath the earth and in the heavens, making the weaker argument stronger, and ^{19c} teaching these same things to others.” It goes something like that. And, indeed, you yourselves have seen a Socrates, in Aristophanes’³⁷ comedy, being carried about the place, claiming to walk on air, and blabbering a lot of other nonsense about which I have no knowledge, great or small. And I am not speaking out of

disrespect for this sort of knowledge, if anyone is wise in such matters. I hope that Meletus' charges are never so numerous as to make me do that. But the fact is, men of Athens, I have no involvement with these matters. And I am calling you, the majority of you, as witnesses, ^{19d} and I think those of you who have ever heard me engaging in discourse, as so many of you have, should instruct one another and inform one another. Yes, you should tell one another if any of you have ever heard me discoursing on such matters to any extent, great or small. And from this you will realise that the other things that most people say about me are just like these accusations. In fact, not one of them is true, and if you have heard from anyone that I undertake to educate people and charge money for doing so, that is not true either, although I would regard this too as a ^{19e} fine accomplishment, if someone were able to educate people, as Gorgias⁴ of Leontini does, Prodicus ^{20a} please, and persuade the young to abandon the company of their own people, consort with them, pay their fees, and feel grateful besides. And I have become aware that there is also another wise man, a Parian, who has arrived here in town, for I happened to visit a man who has spent more money on sophists than everyone put together, Callias, the son of Hipponicus. So, I asked him about his two sons. "Callias," said I, "if your two sons happened to be colts or calves, we would be able to acquire ^{20b} an overseer for them, and pay someone likely to make them noble and good in their appropriate excellence, and that person would be a horse-trainer or a farmer. But now, since they are two human beings, whom do you intend to acquire as their overseer? Who is there who is knowledgeable in excellence of this kind, human and civic excellence? For I presume you have considered this, since you have two sons. Is there such a person or is there not?" I asked. "There certainly is," he replied. "Who is it?" I asked, "and where is he from, and how much does he charge to teach this?" "He is Evenus⁵, ^{5a} Parian," he replied, "and he charges five

minae.” And I would congratulate Evenus, if he ^{20c} were truly to possess this skill and teach it for such a modest fee. I, for my part, would have been proud and given myself airs if I had this knowledge. But the fact is, men of Athens, I do not have this knowledge. Now, one of you may perhaps object, “But, Socrates, what is it that you do? What is the origin of these slanders against you? Yes, surely this rumour and talk would not have arisen unless, by your conduct, you stood out from everyone else, unless you were behaving differently from ^{20d} most people. So tell us what it is so that we do not make rash judgements about you.” I think that whoever says this is raising some fair questions, and I shall try to show you what exactly it is that has given rise to this reputation of mine, and the slander too. Listen then, and some of you will probably think that I am joking, but mark my words, I shall tell you the whole truth. For I have acquired this reputation, men of Athens, only because of a particular kind of wisdom. What kind of wisdom is this? The particular wisdom that is, perhaps, human wisdom. In fact, I probably am ^{20e} wise in that wisdom, and perhaps those men whom I mentioned earlier may be wise with a wisdom that is greater than human wisdom. Otherwise I do not know what to say, for I myself have no knowledge of it, and anyone who says so is lying and is out to slander me. And do not raise a clamour against me, men of Athens, even if you think I am speaking boastfully. In fact, the word I shall speak is not my own; rather, I shall refer to a trustworthy speaker. For I shall provide you with the god of Delphi⁶ as witness of my own wisdom – if, indeed, it is wisdom – and of the sort of wisdom ^{21a} it is. Indeed, I presume you knew Chaerophon. He was my friend from my youngest years, and a friend of your democracy too, and he joined you in your recent exile and returned along with you. Well, you also know what Chaerophon was like and how impulsive he was in anything he took on. And, in fact, he once went to Delphi and dared to consult the oracle about this, and, as I said, please do

not raise a clamour, gentlemen – yes, he asked if anyone was wiser than me. So the Pythia⁸ answered that no one was wiser. And his brother, who is here, will be your witness of this, since the man himself is dead.

21b

Now, consider my reasons for saying all this, for I am going to set out for you the origin of the slander against me. Indeed, when I heard this, I reflected upon it as follows. “What exactly does the god mean, and what on earth is the riddle he poses? For I myself am aware of being wise in nothing great or small, so what precisely does he mean when he says I am the wisest? Of course he cannot be lying, since that is not lawful for him.” And I was perplexed for a considerable time as to what precisely he meant. Then, with much reluctance, I turned to a process of enquiry that went something like this. I went to one of the people who seemed to be wise on the assumption ^{21c} that there, if anywhere, I could refute the oracular utterance and show the oracle, “This person is wiser than me, but you said I was the wisest.” Now, I need not name the man, but it was one of our politicians I was examining, and my experience, men of Athens, was somewhat as follows. As I engaged him in discourse, it seemed to me that, although this man was thought wise by many other people and most of all by himself, he was not wise. So, I then attempted to show him that, although he believed himself to be wise, he was not wise. As a result, I was hated by him, and by ^{21d} many of those present. I reckoned as I was going that I am wiser than this man, for it is likely that neither of us knows anything noble and good, but he thinks he knows something, when he does not know, while I do not actually know. I do not even think that I know. So perhaps in this one minor respect, I am wiser than he is, because I do not think I know what I do not know. I then went to someone else, to one of the people who seemed wiser than that man, and I came to the very same conclusions, and in this case too I was hated by him,

and by many others. No, after this I kept on going, aware that I was hated, grieving and fearful, but it seemed ^{21e} necessary nevertheless to set the work of the god above all else. In considering the meaning of the oracle, I had to go to all those who seemed to know something. And by the dog, men of Athens, ^{22a} for I must speak the truth to you, my experience was something like this. When it came to being wise, those with the most exalted reputations seemed to me, as I searched at the god's behest, well nigh worst-off, while other men, of lower repute, were better off. So I must recount my wanderings to you, and the labours I undertook, only to find the oracle irrefutable. For after the politicians I went to the poets – the tragedians, the dithyrambists and the ^{22b} rest – expecting in this case to show myself up, blatantly, as being more ignorant than they. So, selecting poems of theirs that in my opinion they had crafted most intricately, I would question them as to what they meant in order to learn something from them in the process. Now, gentlemen, I am ashamed to recount the truth to you, but it must be spoken nevertheless. For in a sense, almost anyone who was present might have spoken better than the poets about the poems they themselves had composed. So in the case of the poets too, I quickly realised that it is not by wisdom that they compose their works, but by nature, and by being inspired, just like the prophets and deliverers of ^{22c} oracles. For these people also say a great deal, and it is beautiful too, but they know nothing about what they are saying. It was evident to me that the poets were in a similar predicament, and I became aware at the same time that because of their poetry they also thought themselves the wisest of men in general, when they were not. So I left their company too, thinking I was better off than they are, in the same way that I was better off than the politicians. Then finally I came to the craftsmen, for I myself was aware that I, in a sense, had no knowl- ^{22d} edge, and yet I knew I would find that their knowledge was extensive and beautiful. Well, I was

not deceived in this. They did know things I did not know, and in this respect they were wiser than me. But, men of Athens, it seemed to me that the pre-eminent craftsmen also had the same failing as the poets. Because they exercised their skill so beautifully, they each deemed themselves extremely wise in other matters too, matters of great importance, and this error of theirs obscured that wisdom. So I asked myself, on behalf of the oracle, whether I should accept my present con- ^{22e} dition, neither wise in any of their wisdom nor foolish in their folly, or possess their wisdom and their folly. So I responded to myself and the oracle that it was better for me to remain as I was. From this process of investigation, men of Athens, I have incurred a great deal of hatred of ^{23b} Socrates. And what is more, he is using my name, using me as an example, as if he were to say, "He among you, O humans, is wisest who has realised, like Socrates, that he is in truth worth nothing when it comes to wisdom." So to this very day I go about conducting these investigations, seeking out at the god's behest anyone, either citizen or stranger, whom I think to be wise, and once he seems not so to me, to assist the god I show that he is not wise. And because of this occupation I have no time for any involvement in civic affairs worth mentioning, or for any private concerns either, but I am in ^{23c} utter poverty because of my servitude to the god. As well as this, the young people follow me about of their own accord, those with the most free time who belong to the wealthiest families. They enjoy hearing people being examined, and they often imitate me themselves when, in turn, they attempt to examine others. And they then find, I am sure, a whole host of people who think they know something, when they know little or ^{23d} nothing. So as a result, those whom they cross-examine get angry with me rather than themselves, and they say that Socrates is a pestilence who corrupts the young. And whenever anyone asks them what I do and what I teach, they have nothing to say. They have no idea, and so that they do

not seem to be at a loss, they repeat the convenient charges made against all philosophers that ‘they investigate the heavens above and the earth beneath’, and that ‘they do not believe in the gods’, and that ‘they make the weaker argument stronger’. For in my view, they are reluctant to speak the truth and admit that they are being exposed, pretending to know when they know nothing.

23e

Now, because, as I see it, these influential people are ambitious, forceful and numerous, and because they speak about me assertively and persuasively, they have assailed your ears over many years with their comprehensive slanders. On this basis, Meletus has proceeded against me – Anytus too and Lycon – Meletus being ^{24a} angry on the poets’ behalf, Anytus on behalf of the craftsmen and politicians, Lycon on behalf of the rhetoricians. And so, as I said at the outset, I would be surprised if I were able, in the short time available, to rid you of this slander when it has become so pervasive. There you have the truth, men of Athens. I have concealed nothing, significant or insignificant, and I am speaking without any restraint. And yet, I know quite well that these are the very reasons I am hated, which ^{24b} proves that I am speaking the truth. This is the slander against me, and these are its causes, and if you investigate these matters, either now or in the future, you shall find that it is so. Now, this defence that I offer you against the accusations made by my first accusers should be sufficient. I shall attempt to follow this with a defence against Meletus – that good man and friend of the city, so he proclaims – and the later accusers too. Well then, we should take their affidavit in turn as if they were a different set of accusers. It goes somewhat as follows: it says that Socrates acts ^{24c} unjustly by corrupting the young and believing not in the gods the city believes in, but in other novel divine forces. That is the sort of charge it is, and we should scrutinise every detail of this charge. Well then, the charge

states that I am acting unjustly by corrupting the young. And yet I state, men of Athens, that Meletus is acting unjustly because he is making a joke of a serious matter by blithely bringing people to trial, pretending to be serious and concerned about matters that he has never cared about at all. But I shall also attempt to demonstrate to you that this is the case.

24d

“Come Meletus, tell me. Do you not attach great importance to the younger generation being in the best condition possible?” “I do.” “Come on then, tell these people: who is it who makes them better? Yes, you obviously know who it is, since you care. For you claim to have discovered their corrupter – me – and you are bringing me before these men, and making an accusation. So come on, tell them who makes young people better, tell them who this is. Do you see, Meletus, that you are silent and have nothing to say? But do you not think this is shameful and enough to prove what I am saying: you do not care. But speak, good man, who makes them better?” “The laws.” “But, best of men, I did not ask you that. No, I asked who the person is who knows this in the first ^{24e} place, who knows the laws.” “These people, Socrates, the jurors.” “What are you saying, Meletus? Are the jurors here able to educate the young and make them better?” “Very much so.” “All the jurors, or just some of them?” “All of them.” “By Hera, that is good news. You are saying that there is a whole host of people who benefit the young. And what about those who are listening in, do they make them better or not?” “Those people too.”

25a

“What about those who sit on the Council?” “Those who sit on the Council too.” “Well, Meletus, perhaps those in the Assembly, the assemblymen, corrupt the young? Or do they all make them better too?” “They do too.” “So it seems that all the Athenians make them noble and good, except me. I alone corrupt them. Is this what you are saying?” “That is what I am saying most

emphatically.” “Then you have laid great misfortune at my door. Now, answer this question for me. Do you think this is also the case with horses, that everyone makes them better while there is one person who ^{25b} corrupts them? Or is it completely the other way around? There is one person, or very few – the horse-trainers – who can make them better, while most people corrupt the horses if they deal with them or use them? Isn’t this the case, Meletus, both with horses and all animals? It is of course entirely so, whether yourself and Anytus confirm it or deny it. Indeed, it would be a great blessing to the young people if only one person corrupted them while everyone else benefited them. But in ^{25c} fact, Meletus, you are demonstrating quite adequately that you have not given a moment’s thought to the young people, and you are blatantly exposing your own uncaring attitude. You do not care about the issues on which you are prosecuting me. And, by Zeus, Meletus, tell us this besides. Is it better to dwell among good citizens or wicked ones? Answer, my man, for I have not asked you a difficult question. Do not the wicked do some harm to those who are always closest to them, while the good do some good?” “Yes, certainly.” “Now, is there anyone who prefers to be harmed by his associates rather than benefited? Answer, ^{25d} good man. In fact, the law demands that you answer. Is there anyone who wishes to be harmed?” “No, of course not.” “Come then, are you prosecuting me here for corrupting the young and making them more wicked intentionally or unintentionally?” “I say intentionally.” “What is this, Meletus? Are you, at your age, so much wiser than I am at my age that you have recognised that the bad people always do some harm to those closest to themselves, and the good ^{25e} do some good, while I am in such depths of ignorance that I do not even realise that if I make any of my fellows wicked, I run the risk of being harmed by him? And so, according to you, I perform such an evil deed as this intentionally? No, Meletus, you do not convince me of any of

this, and I ^{26a} do not think anyone is convinced either. Well then, either I do not corrupt them or, if I corrupt them, I do so unintentionally, and so in either case you are speaking falsely. But if I corrupt them unintentionally, you should not, by law, bring me to court over a mistake like this. Instead, you should instruct me and rebuke me in private. For it is obvious that if I am given instruction, I shall stop whatever I am doing unintentionally. Yet, although you have avoided my company and been reluctant to instruct me, you nevertheless bring me here to court, where, by law you should bring those who are in need of punishment rather than instruction.”

^{26b}

In any case, men of Athens, it is obvious at this stage, as I said, that Meletus has never shown any great concern for these matters, not in the least. “Nevertheless, Meletus, tell us in what way do I corrupt the young, according to you? Or is it quite obvious from the charge you have brought against me that I do so by teaching them not to believe in the gods the city believes in, but in other novel divine forces? Don’t you say that I corrupt them by teaching them this?” “Yes certainly, that is what I am saying, emphatically.” “Well, Meletus, by those very gods we are now talking about, speak more clearly, both to myself ^{26c} and to these gentlemen here, for I cannot understand you. Are you saying that I teach them to believe in some gods, and that I myself actually believe in gods, and am not a total atheist, and unjust in that sense? Is your charge against me that the gods I believe in are not the gods of the city, but different? Or are you claiming that I myself do not believe in gods at all, and I teach these doctrines to others?” “That is what I am saying, that you do not believe in gods at all.”

^{26d}

“You surprise me, Meletus. What makes you say this? Do I not actually believe that the sun and the moon are gods, as other men do?” “No, by Zeus, gentlemen of the jury, since he declares

that the sun is stone and the moon is earth.” “Dear Meletus, do you think that you are accusing Anaxagoras? And do you have such contempt for these men, and think them so unlettered as not to know that the books of Anaxagoras of Clazomenae are full of these doctrines? And do the young really learn these doctrines from me, ^{26e} when they can sometimes buy them in the market for a drachma at most, and laugh at Socrates if he pretends they are his own, especially when they are so strange? But, by Zeus, is this really what you think? Do I not believe in a single god?” “By Zeus, you do not, not at all.” “You have no credibility, Meletus, and I do not think that even you believe this yourself.” Indeed, in my opinion, men of Athens, this man is extremely arrogant and unrestrained, and has ^{27a} simply brought this charge in a spirit of arrogance, unrestraint and impetuosity. Yes, he is like someone posing a riddle as a test: “So, will Socrates the wise recognise that I am making a joke and contradicting myself, or will I deceive him and everyone else who hears me?” In fact, the man appears to me to contradict himself in the charge, as if he were saying, “Socrates is acting unjustly by not believing in gods, yet believing in gods.” But this is a joke. Join with me then, gentlemen, and consider in detail how, in my view, he is saying this. You should answer our questions, Meletus, ^{27b} while you gentlemen should recall the favour I asked of you at the beginning. Do not cause a commotion if I conduct the discussion in my accustomed manner. “Is there anyone, Meletus, who believes that there are human affairs but does not believe there are human beings? Let him answer, and, gentlemen, do not make one commotion after another. Is there anyone who does not believe in horses, yet believes in equestrian affairs, or who does not believe there are flute players, but does believe in matters concerned with flute-playing? Best of men, there is not. Since you do not wish to respond, I am telling you, and everyone else here. But you must at least answer my next question. Is there anyone who believes

that there are divine ^{27c} forces, but does not believe in divinities?" "There is not." "How good of you to answer, reluctantly, under compulsion from these men here. Now, you claim that I believe in, and teach, divine forces, never mind if they are novel or ancient. According to you I believe in divine forces anyway, and you have even sworn this in your indictment. But if I believe in divine forces it really is necessary, of course, that I believe in divinities. Isn't this the case? Yes, it is. Well, I am presuming you agree since you won't answer. And do we not hold that the divinities are either gods or the children of gods. Do you agree or not?"

^{27d}

"Very much so." "Therefore, if in fact, as you say, I hold that there are divinities, and the divinities are gods, this would constitute what I refer to as your riddling and jesting, saying that I do not believe in gods and then again that I believe in gods, since I do actually believe in divinities. Yet if, on the other hand, the divinities are illegitimate children of gods, born of nymphs or anyone else who is said to be their mother, is there any man who could believe that there are children of gods, but not believe there are gods? Yes, that would be just as strange as someone believing that there is off- ^{27e} spring of horses and asses, namely mules, and not believing that there are horses and asses. But Meletus, you really must have been testing us out here when you brought this charge, or else you were at a loss for a genuine injustice to charge me with. But you could never persuade anyone possessed of even a little intelligence that the same person can believe in divine forces and matters divine, and yet at the same time believe neither in divinities, nor gods, nor heroes. You simply ^{28a} could not do it." Well then, men of Athens, I do not think much defence is needed to show that I am not acting unjustly, based upon Meletus' charge. Even this should suffice. But mark my words, what I said earlier is true. I have attracted a lot of hatred from a lot of people, and this is

what will convict me, if I am convicted, not Meletus, not Anytus, but the slander and malice of the multitude. This indeed has convicted many other good men, and I think it will continue to do so. There is no fear it will ^{28b} stop with me. Now, someone might perhaps say, “Are you not ashamed, Socrates, that you have followed such a course as this and now risk being executed as a result?” To him I would respond, justifiably, “What you are saying is not right, sir, if you think a man of any merit at all should reckon his chances of living or dying whenever he engages in action, and not consider this alone: whether he is acting justly or unjustly, doing the work of a good man or a bad man.” For, according to your ^{28c} argument, all of the demi-gods who met their death at Troy would be worthless, including the son of Thetis, who was so contemptuous of danger once the alternative was disgrace. Thus, when his mother, a goddess, said to him when he was eager to slay Hector – she said something like this I think – “My son, if you are going to avenge the murder of your friend Patroclus and slay Hector, you yourself shall be slain,” she said, “for straightaway after Hector’s death, destiny awaits you ^{28d} as a bad man who does not avenge his friends, so he said, “May I die straightaway, as soon as I have inflicted justice upon this unjust man, so that I remain not here by the curved ships, a laughing stock and a burden to the earth.”¹⁰ Do you imagine that he thought about death or danger? For in truth, men of Athens, this is how matters stand. Wherever a man may position himself, thinking it best to be there, or wherever he is positioned by his commander, there in my view he should remain facing danger, reckoning nothing, neither death nor anything else, as worse than ^{28e} disgrace. Now, I would have been acting terribly, men of Athens, if I had remained at my post, just like anyone else, running the risk of being killed, when my commanders, chosen by yourselves, ^{29a} placed me in the ranks at Potidaea¹¹, Amphipolis and Delium, yet deserted my post for fear of death or for any other reason,

when the god, as I believed and understood, positioned me where I had to live, practising philosophy and examining myself and others. Yes, that would be terrible, and in truth anyone might justly haul me into court for not believing there are gods, disobeying the oracle, being afraid of death, and thinking I am wise when I am not. For I tell you, gentlemen, fearing death is no different from thinking you are wise when you are not, for it is thinking you know what you do not know. In fact, no one actually knows whether death may not turn out to be the greatest good of all for man, and yet they fear it, as if they know quite well it is the greatest of ^{29b} evils. And is this not the most disgraceful ignorance, thinking you know what you do not know? And to this extent, in this case too, gentlemen, I am perhaps different from most people, and if I were to claim to be wiser than anyone, in any respect, it would be in this: I do not know enough about what is in Hades, so I do not presume that I know either. But I do know that it is bad, and a ^{29c} disgrace, to act unjustly and to disobey a superior, be he god or human. So I shall fear and flee from the evils I know to be evils, and not from what might, for all I know, actually be good. And so, even if you let me go now, ignoring Anytus, who said that either I should not have been brought to court at all, or since I have been brought to court I must be put to death, warning you that if I get off your sons will be soon totally corrupted, all of them, by practising what Socrates teaches; if in response to this you were to say to me, “Socrates, on this occasion we shall not heed Anytus. Instead we shall let you go, but on this condition: that you no longer spend your time in this enquiry, ^{29d} nor engage in philosophy, and should you ever be caught doing so again, you shall die,” now if, as I said, you were to let me go on these conditions, I would say to you, “Men of Athens, I embrace you and I love you, but I shall heed the god rather than you, and as long as I am alive, and able to do so, I shall not cease engaging in philosophy, exhorting you, and pointing out to any one of you

whom I ever meet, saying in my usual manner, ‘best of men, you are Athenians, citizens of the greatest city, most renowned for her wisdom and power. Are you not ashamed that you care about ^{29e} piling up as much money, reputation and honour as you can, while giving no care or thought to wisdom and truth and how your soul may be as good as it can be?’ And if one of you disputes this, and says that he does care, I will not let him go immediately, nor shall I depart. No, I shall question, ^{30a} examine and cross-examine him, and if I think he has not acquired excellence, but he says that he has, I shall rebuke him for attaching the least value to what is most valuable, and considerable value to things of lesser worth. And I shall do this to anyone I come across, old or young, stranger or fellow citizen, but especially to you, my fellow citizens, as you are my closest kin. For mark my words, the god commands this, and I think no greater good has yet come to you in this city than my service to the god. For my only occupation is to go about persuading you, old and young, ^{30b} to care neither for your bodies nor for your money more or with more intensity than your soul, so that it may be as excellent as it can be. So I say, ‘Excellence does not come from money; but from excellence, money, and everything else that is good, comes to mankind, in private or in public.’ Now, if I corrupt the young by saying all this, this would be harmful. But if anyone claims that I say anything else apart from this, he is talking nonsense. And so I would say, “Men of Athens, whether you obey Anytus or not, whether you let me go or not, I shall never change my ways, not ^{30c} even if I am to die many times over.” Men of Athens, do not create a commotion. I asked you not to make a commotion over what I said, so please abide by my request and listen. And in fact I think you will profit from listening, for I am now going to tell you something else at which you will probably make an outcry, but please do not do so, not at all. For mark my words, if you put me to death, being the sort of person I say that I am, you will

harm yourselves more than you harm me. In fact, neither Meletus nor Anytus could harm me, for that would not be possible, because I do not think it permissible ^{30d} that a better man be harmed by a worse. Yes, he may perhaps put me to death, exile me, or deprive me of my rights, and although he probably thinks these are great evils, and others presumably think so too, I do not think so. No, it is a far greater evil to do what he is now doing: attempting to put a man to death in an unjust manner. So, men of Athens, I am not making my defence on my own behalf, as someone might presume, but on behalf of you, lest you make a mistake concerning the gift God gave you by condemning me. For if you kill me, you will not easily find someone else like me, who literally – ^{30e} even if it sounds comical to say so – is attached to the city by god, as though it were a great, thoroughbred steed, sluggish due to its size, that needs to be woken up by a sort of gadfly. Well, I am like that gadfly whom the god has attached to the city, the sort of person who never stops rousing, persuading, and censuring each one of you, alighting upon you all day long, wherever you go.

^{31a}

Now, you will not easily get someone else like me, gentlemen, so if you take my advice you will spare me. But you may perhaps be angry with me, like people woken from their slumbers, and swat me on Anytus' advice, and kill me without giving it a second thought. But then you would live out the rest of your lives in slumber, unless the god, out of concern for you, were to send you someone else like me. And from this you may recognise that I am such a person, given to the city by the god, for ^{31b} it seems scarcely human that I have neglected all business of my own and suffered the neglect of my family affairs for so many years now, constantly busy with your concerns, coming to you like a father or elder brother, urging you to care for excellence. Now, if I derived any advantage from all this, or was paid for these exhortations of mine, I might have some motive. But now you

surely see for yourselves that my accusers, although they make all these other accusations without a hint of shame, were not so shameless as to bring witnesses to say that I ever charged a fee or asked for ^{31c} one. Indeed, I think I am providing sufficient evidence that I am speaking the truth, by my poverty. Now, you may perhaps think it strange that I go around giving this advice and meddling in your affairs in private, and dare not appear before your assembly in public and give advice to the city. You have heard me describing the reason for this on many occasions, in many places. Something divine and miraculous comes to me, which Meletus makes a joke of in the charge that ^{31d} he brought. I have had it from childhood. It is a sort of voice that arises, and whenever it arises it always turns me away from doing something I am about to do, but it never urges me on. This is what opposes my engagement in civic affairs, and I think it is absolutely right to oppose. For mark my words, men of Athens, if, in times gone by, I had attempted to engage in civic affairs, I would have been put to death long ago, and would have benefited neither yourselves nor myself. And ^{31e} you should not be angry with me for speaking the truth, for no one who genuinely opposes yourselves, or any other multitude at all, preventing numerous injustices and illegalities from taking place in a city, will be safe. Rather, anyone who is actually fighting on the side of justice and who ^{32a} intends to be safe, even for a short time, must act privately rather than publicly.

^{32b} men of Athens, I have never yet held any other office in the city, I did serve on the Council, and, as it happened, our tribe, Antiochis, made up the commission when you decided to judge, as a single group, the ten generals who failed to recover the casualties of the naval battle, which was contrary to the law, as you all accepted afterwards. On that occasion, I was the only Council member who opposed your doing anything contrary to the laws, and I voted against you. And while the orators were

ready to charge and arrest me, and you were all encouraging them and shouting at ^{32c} me, I thought that I should side with law and justice, in spite of the danger, rather than side with yourselves in making an unjust decision for fear of imprisonment or death. This all happened while the city was still under democratic rule, but once the oligarchy was established, the Thirty¹³, for their part, sent for me and four others to the Tholos and ordered us to bring Leon¹⁴ the Salaminian from Salamis to be executed. In fact, they often gave orders like this to many others as well, wishing to implicate as many people as possible in their actions. Here ^{32d} again, I demonstrated, not in word but in deed, that I really do not care about death at all, if it is not too blunt to say so, yet I am extremely careful to perform no unjust or unholy deed. Indeed, that regime, powerful and all as it was, did not intimidate me into performing an unjust act. No, once we had come out of the Tholos, the other four left for Salamis and fetched Leon¹⁵ while I left and went home. For this I would probably have been executed had the regime not fallen so quickly.

^{32e}

Of these events you will have numerous witnesses. Well then, do you think I would have survived all these years had I taken to public life and, acting as befits a good man, had sided with the just and set that above all else, as one should? Far ^{33a} from it, men of Athens, nor indeed would anyone else. But throughout my entire life, both in public, if I ever engaged in such activities, and also in private, you will see that I am the very same. I have never gone along with anyone in anything contrary to justice, not even with those whom my slanderers proclaim to be my pupils. Yet although I have never been any man's teacher, if anyone wishes to listen to me as I speak and go about my business, I begrudge that to no one, old or young.

^{33b}

Neither do I engage in discourse only when I am paid, and not otherwise. No, I submit myself to questioning by rich and poor alike, and anyone who wishes may hear what I say in reply. And if any of them happens to become a good person or a bad one, I may not properly be held responsible since I neither taught nor promised to teach them anything. And if anyone says he has ever learned or heard something from me in private, which everyone else has not, I assure you that he is not speaking the truth.

33c

But why exactly is it that some people enjoy spending so much time with me? Listen, men of Athens, for I have told you the whole truth already. They enjoy hearing me examine people who think they are wise when they are not. It is not an unpleasant pastime. But, as I say, I have been ordered by the god to do this, through prophecies, dreams and any other means whereby a divine portion has ever ordered a human being to do anything at all.

33d

All of this is true, men of Athens, and easily tested. For if I am indeed corrupting some young people, and have already corrupted others, surely some of them now grown older, realising that I once gave them evil counsel when they were young, should come forward at this stage to accuse me and get their revenge. And if they did not wish to do this themselves, some of their own relatives, their fathers, brothers or other family members, should now remember any evil their kinfolk may have suffered at my hands, if there was any, and take their revenge. In any case, I can see 33e a lot of them here. First and foremost is Crito, a man of my own age and deme, the father of Critoboulus here; then Lysanias of Sphettos, the father of this man, Aeschines; Antiphon of Cephissus too, the father of Epigenes. Then there are others whose brothers have been involved in this occupation of mine, Nicostratus the son of

Theozotidus, the brother of Theodotus, and since Theodotus is dead, he for one could not have implored his brother not to make the accusation. I see Paralus, son of Demodocus, whose brother was Theages; and here is Adimantus, the son of ^{34a} Ariston, and this is his brother, Plato; and there is Aeantodorus and his brother, Apollodorus. And I could also mention many others to you, any one of whom Meletus really should have introduced as a witness in the course of his own speech. But if he forgot at the time, let him introduce them now. I shall yield my place to him, and if he has such a witness, let him say so. But you will find the complete opposite, gentlemen. They are all ready to side with me, the corrupter, the man who, according to Meletus and Anytus, inflicts harm upon their own kindred. Now, those who have ^{34b} been corrupted might perhaps have reason to side with me, but what reason would their uncorrupted, older relatives have for siding with me, apart from the right and just reason that they are aware that Meletus is speaking falsely, while I am speaking the truth? There it is, gentlemen. This is more or less all I have to say in my defence. But some of you may well take offence when he recalls how he himself, while contesting a lesser charge than ^{34c} this one, begged and implored the jurors, in floods of tears, parading his own children before them, other members of his household too and lots of his friends, just to arouse as much pity as he could. And now he finds that I do nothing of the sort even though I am apparently facing the utmost peril. So someone might perhaps think like this, be hardened against me, and enraged by these very issues may cast his vote in anger. Well, if any of you are in this situation, and I am not ^{34d} actually maintaining that you are, but if you are, I think it would be reasonable for me to speak to this person and say, “Best of men, I too have some family members, for, as Homer puts it, ‘I am not born of oak and rock’, but of men, and so I have kinfolk and sons too, men of Athens, three of them, one already a young man, two still children. Nevertheless,

I shall not parade any of them here before you and beg you to vote for my acquittal.” Well then, why won’t I do any of this? It is not out of defiance, men of Athens, or any disrespect for you. Whether or not I am ^{34e} courageous in the face of death is another matter, but in view of my own reputation and that of yourselves and the entire city, I do not think it good that I do anything like this at my age and with the name I have. For whether this is true or false, it has been decided that Socrates is some- ^{35a} how superior to most people. Now, if those of you who are reputed to be superior in wisdom or courage, or in any other excellence, were to behave in this way, that would be a disgrace, like people I have seen on trial on a number of occasions, reputable people indeed, yet behaving in an extraordinary manner, as if they thought something awful would befall them if they were executed, as if they were actually going to live forever if you did not execute them. To me they seem to bring shame upon the city, so that any visitor would presume that the Athenians, superior in ^{35b} excellence, whom they select from among themselves to hold high office and other positions of honour, are no better than women. Indeed, men of Athens, these are actions which you should not perform if you have any worthy reputation at all, and you should not allow us to perform them either. Instead, you should demonstrate that you would much rather vote to convict someone who puts on such a pitiful performance, and makes a laughing stock of the city, than someone who holds his peace.

^{35c}

Quite apart from reputation, gentlemen, it does not seem right to me either to implore a juror or to get acquitted by begging. It should be done through instruction and persuasion. For a juror is not there to bestow favours in matters of justice, but to give judgements, and he has sworn not to show favour to people he prefers, but to deliver justice in accordance with the laws. Therefore, you should not make a habit of breaking your oaths,

nor should we get you into that habit either, for neither of us would be acting with due reverence. So, men of Athens, do not expect ^{35d} me to behave towards you in a manner I regard as neither noble nor just nor holy, most especially, by Zeus, when I am actually being charged with impiety by Meletus over there. For it is clear that if I were to persuade and compel you by begging you, when you have sworn this oath, I would be teaching you not to believe there are gods, and would, in effect, whilst defending myself, accuse myself of not believing in gods. But this is not how matters stand. Far from it, for I believe in them, men of Athens, as none of my accusers believes, and I commit to you and to the god my cause to be judged, in whatever way may be best for me and for you.

AFTER THE GUILTY VERDICT

^{35e}

There are many reasons, men of Athens, why I am not troubled by this outcome, that you voted to ^{36a} convict me, and what has happened is not unexpected. But I am much more surprised at the number of votes on each side. For I never thought the difference in the votes was going to be so small, I thought it would be larger. But now, it seems, if a mere thirty votes had gone the other way, I would have been acquitted. In fact, even as it stands, I think I have escaped Meletus, and not only escaped him, but it is obvious to anyone that if Anytus and Lycon had not come forward to accuse me too, ^{36b} he would even have been fined a thousand drachmas for not securing one fifth of the votes. So, this man proposes the death penalty for me. So be it. What alternative penalty shall I propose to you, men of Athens? Obviously, it should be a penalty I deserve. What, then? What do I deserve to suffer or pay out, all because I did not live a quiet life, and cared not for what most people care for – money making, affairs of the household, military rank, political status, public ^{36c} office in general, and the alliances and factions that

arise in the city? In fact, I thought myself too fair-minded to survive any involvement in any of this, so I did not go where I was to be of no benefit to yourselves or to myself. I went instead to each person individually, where I was going to confer the greatest benefit possible as I declare, by trying to persuade each of you to care, first and foremost, for himself rather than anything that belongs to himself, so that he might be as good and as wise as possible, to care for the city itself before anything that belongs to the city, and to ^{36d} care for everything else in like manner. So what should happen to me for being this sort of person? What do I deserve? Something good, men of Athens, if I must propose a penalty based upon what I truly deserve, and it should be good in a way that is appropriate for me. Well, what is appropriate for a poor man, a benefactor, who needs leisure in order to exhort you? There is nothing more appropriate, men of Athens, than free meals in the Prytaneum¹⁶. That is far more appropriate for me than it is for anyone who wins at the Olympic Games with a horse, or two horses or four horses. For while he makes you seem to be blessed, I make you blessed in reality, and while he has no ^{36e} need of sustenance, I need it. So, if I must propose a penalty I justly deserve, this is what I propose, ^{37a} free meals in the Prytaneum. Now, perhaps, when I say this, you think I am speaking defiantly, in much the same way as I spoke about recourse to pity and to pleading, but this is not the case, men of Athens. Rather, I am convinced that I have never intentionally wronged anyone. But I am not convincing you of this because we have had such a short time to discuss it, since, in my opinion, if you had a law, as other peoples do when a death penalty is involved, not to judge the case in a single day but over several days, you would be convinced. But it is not easy now to dispel these mighty slanders in ^{37b} such a short time. So, being convinced that I have not wronged anyone else, I cannot possibly wrong myself and say that I deserve something bad and propose such a penalty for myself. Why should I? For fear of

suffering the penalty Meletus proposes when I said I do not know if it is good or bad? Or should I select an alternative that I know quite well to be bad, and propose that instead? What about imprisonment? But why should I live in prison, in slavery to the officials who hold office at ^{37c} the time, the Eleven? Or what about a fine, and imprisonment until I pay it? But in my case, this is the same as the other suggestion, for I do not have money with which to pay the fine. Well then, shall I propose exile as the penalty? Indeed, you might well accept that for me. Yet I would be gripped by an intense love of life, men of Athens, if I were so irrational that I could not figure out that while you, my fellow citizens, proved unable to tolerate my behaviour and my arguments, ^{37d} and they became so burdensome and detestable to you that you are now seeking to be quit of them, other people ... well, would they tolerate them more readily? Far from it, men of Athens. And what a nice life I would have in exile, a man of my age, moving from city to city, constantly being banished. For I know full well that wherever I go, the young people will listen to what I say, just as they do here, and if I drive them away they themselves will persuade their elders to banish me, ^{37e} and if I do not drive them away, their fathers and relations will banish me for their sakes. Now, someone might perhaps say, "Socrates, if you kept quiet and lived a quiet life, wouldn't you be able to live on, once we had cast you out?" The most difficult thing of all is to convince some of you on this issue, for if I say that this would constitute disobedience to the god and that is why I cannot hold my peace, you do not believe me as you think I am being ironical.

^{38a}

And if I also go on to say the highest good for a man is to engage in discourse every day about excellence, and the other issues on which you have heard me discoursing, and examining myself and others, and that for a human being an unexamined life is not worth living, you are even less convinced by what I say. But

although that is how matters stand, as I declare, gentlemen, it is not easy to convince you. Besides, I am not used to the idea that I deserve anything bad. If I had money, ^{38b} I might have proposed as large a fine as I could afford to pay, for that would have done me no harm. But at the moment I do not have the money, unless of course you propose as much of a fine as I am able to pay. I might perhaps be able to pay you one mina of silver, so I am proposing this amount. But, men of Athens, Plato here, Crito and Critoboulus and Apollodorus are encouraging me to propose thirty minae. They will act as sureties. So I propose that amount, and they will be your sureties for the money. They are trustworthy.

AFTER THE DEATH SENTENCE

Men of Athens, all to save a little time, you will be notorious, and be accused of killing Socrates, ^{38c} a wise man, by those who wish to reproach this city. For people who wish to revile you will indeed say I am wise, even if I am not. In any case, if you had waited a short while you would have obtained this result of its own accord, for you surely see my age, that I am now at a late stage of life and close to death. I am saying this, not to all of you, but to those who voted for my execution.

^{38d}

And I also say to these very people, perhaps you think, gentlemen, I have been convicted by being at a loss for the sort of words that would have persuaded you, had I believed I should do and say ^{39b} escape death. No, it is much more difficult to escape wickedness, for that runs faster than death. And now, since I am slow and old, I have been caught by the slower runner, while my accusers, being clever and sharp, have been caught by the faster one, evil. And I shall now depart, sentenced by you to death, while they will depart, sentenced by truth to degeneracy and injustice. And I abide by my penalty, and so do

they. Perhaps, too, this is somehow the way things had to be, and I think it is all in due measure.

39c

Next, I wish to make a prophecy to those of you who voted to condemn me, for I am now at the stage where men prophesy most of all, when they are going to die. For I declare, you gentlemen who have slain me, that immediately after my death you shall meet with a far more grievous punishment, by Zeus, than the death sentence you imposed upon me. For you have done this now, believing that you will avoid giving an account of your life, but I am telling you the very opposite ^{39d} will happen. You will have far more people holding you to account, people whom I restrained until now, although you have been unaware of this. And as they are younger, they will be more severe, and you will be more troubled. For if you think that by killing people you will prevent anyone from reproaching you for not living aright, your thinking is flawed. For this particular means of escape is neither entirely effective nor is it noble, but the noblest and easiest way is not to put other people down, but to make yourself as good as you can possibly be. With these prophetic words I take my leave of those of you who have voted to condemn me.

39e

But I would love to converse about what has happened with those who voted to acquit me, whilst the officials are busy, and before I go to the place where I must die. Please wait with me, ^{40a} gentlemen, for as much time as we are allowed, since there is nothing to prevent us from talking to one another. To you who are my friends, I wish to explain the exact significance of what has happened to me just now. In fact, gentlemen, judges, for you may properly be called judges, something extraordinary has happened to me. For the familiar prophecy of the daimon has always been completely constant throughout my entire life, opposing me even on the most trivial issues, if I was about to do

anything incorrectly. But now, as you yourselves see, something has happened to ^{40b} me which may be thought, and is generally believed, to be the worst of evils. Yet the god's sign did not oppose me as I left my home this morning, nor as I was coming up here to the court, nor in anything I was going to say in my speech. And yet in other discussions, it has stopped me in many places whilst I was still speaking. But now it has not opposed me at all in this matter, not in a single word, or deed. So, what do I suppose is the explanation for this? I shall tell you. In fact it is likely that what has happened to me is actually something good, and those of us who suppose ^{40c} that death is something bad cannot be right to think so. I have strong evidence for this, for the familiar sign would undoubtedly have opposed me unless I was embarking upon a good course of action. But we may also consider, as follows, how great is the hope that death is good? For death is one of two things: either it is like being nothing, and the dead have no awareness of anything or, as we are told, it is a change, and relocation of the soul from this place here to another place. And if it is indeed an absence of awareness, like a sleep in which the sleeper does not even behold a ^{40d} dream, then death would be a wonderful boon. Suppose someone had to select that night wherein he slept beholding no dream, and compare the other days and nights of his own life to this one and say, on reflection, how many days and nights more pleasant than this one he had lived through during his life. There would, I believe, be so few that a common citizen, or even the Great King himself, would find the calculation difficult. And indeed if death is like this, I say it is a boon, for ^{40e} in that case its entire duration is apparently no longer than a single night. But if, on the other hand, death is like making a journey from here to another place, and what is said is true, that all those who have died are actually there, what greater good could there be than this, gentlemen, my judges? For, if anyone arriving in Hades is quit of those self-proclaimed ^{41a} judges, and finds the true judges

who are said to give judgement there – Minos, Rhadamanthus, Aeacus and Triptolemus, and any other demi-gods who were righteous throughout their own lives – would that be an ordinary journey? Or again, wouldn't any of you give anything to meet with Orpheus, Musaeus, Hesiod and Homer? Indeed, I am willing to die again and again repeatedly if all this is true. For I myself would have a wonderful time there comparing my own experiences ^{41b} with theirs, whenever I met up with Palamedes and Ajax, the son of Telamon, and any other men of old who died because of an unjust judgement. I think that would be enjoyable. And, indeed, most important would be to examine the people there, just like the people here, and find out who among them is wise, and who thinks that he is when he is not. Gentlemen, judges, wouldn't anyone give anything to examine the man who led the massive army at Troy, or Odysseus or Sisyphus or ^{41c} countless others one could mention, men and women alike? To engage in discourse with them, associate with them, and examine them, would be an absolute blessing. At any rate, the people there certainly do not execute people for such behaviour. For in general, they are more blessed than those here, and they are already immortal for all time, if what is said is actually true. But you too, gentlemen, judges, should be hopeful in the face of death, and hold this one precept as true: nothing bad comes to a good man either during his life or after death, nor are his ^{41d} affairs neglected by the gods. Nor have my present circumstances come about by accident. Rather, it is obvious to me that at this stage it is better for me to die and be quit of troubles. That is why the sign did not deter me, and I am not at all angered by those who voted against me, or by my accusers. And yet, this was not what they had in mind when they voted to condemn me or accused me. No, their intention was to harm me. For this they deserve censure. Well, I ask this much of ^{41e} them: when my sons are of age, punish them, gentlemen, with the same afflictions as I inflicted upon you, if

you think they are caring for money, or anything else, before excellence, or if they think they are something when they are nothing. Reproach them as I have reproached you, because they care not for what they ought, and think they amount to something when they are worth nothing- ^{42a} ing. And if you do this, myself and my sons will have received just treatment at your hands. But now, it is time to depart, I to die, you to live. Which of us goes to the better lot is unknown to anyone but God.

NOTES

1. The Agora was the civic centre of Athens, where administrative, judicial, commercial, social and religious activities and much more took place. The tables referred to are those set up by bankers and money-changers.
2. Anytus, son of Anthemion (5th/4th century) was an Athenian politician and supporter of the Athenian democracy. He appears as an interlocutor in Plato's *Meno*, where he is antagonistic and threatening towards Socrates.
3. This is a reference to Aristophanes' play, *Clouds*. Aristophanes features as an interlocutor in Plato's *Symposium*.
4. These are three notable Greek sophists of the 5th/4th century. Gorgias and Hippias each have their own eponymous Platonic dialogue. Prodicus and Hippias both appear in Plato's *Protagoras*.
5. Evenus was a late 5th-century sophist and teacher. He is also mentioned in Plato's *Phaedo* and *Phaedrus*.
6. The 'god of Delphi' refers to Apollo, who was believed to speak prophetically through an oracle at his temple in the sacred precinct of Delphi, north-west of Athens.
7. Chaerephon was an Athenian and a loyal friend of Socrates. He also appears in Plato's *Charmides* and *Gorgias*, and in Aristophanes' *Clouds*.
8. The Pythia was the priestess through whom Apollo spoke oracular responses.
9. Anaxagoras was a 5th-century philosopher, born in Clazomenae in Ionia, who spent most of his life in Athens. He was known for his scientific accounts of celestial bodies and phenomena. He is also mentioned in Plato's *Phaedo*, *Cratylus*, *Phaedrus*, *Alcibiades I*, *Gorgias* and *Greater Hippias*.
10. *Iliad* xviii.94 ff.
11. Potidaea, Amphipolis and Delium were sites of battles in the Peloponnesian War, 431-404.
12. This refers to the battle of Arginusae, 406, in the Peloponnesian War, after which the victorious Athenian generals failed to remove the bodies of their fellow comrades from the water because of a storm.
13. The Thirty Tyrants was a brutal oligarchy established in Athens in 404, after its defeat in the Peloponnesian War. The tyranny reigned for nine months before democracy was restored.

14. Leon of Salamis was a general of good reputation who was executed at the behest of the Thirty Tyrants although he had committed no crime.

15. The Leon affair is also recounted by Xenophon in Book II of his *Hellenica*.

16. The Prytaneum was a seat of government and the religious centre of the city. The privilege of dining at the state's expense in the Prytaneum was ordinarily granted to the benefactors of the state, including Olympic victors.

17. One mina was equal to 100 drachmas. A skilled labourer might earn one drachma per day.

20. e wise in that wisdom, and perhaps those men whom I mentioned earlier may be wise with a wisdom that is greater than human wisdom. Otherwise I do not know what to say, for I myself have no knowledge of it, and anyone who says so is lying and is out to slander me. And do not raise a clam- our against me, men of Athens, even if you think I am speaking boastfully. In fact, the word I shall speak is not my own; rather, I shall refer to a trustworthy speaker. For I shall provide you with the god of Delphi⁶ as witness of my own wisdom – if, indeed, it is wisdom – and of the sort of wisdom

Charmides

ΧΑΡΜΙΔΗΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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narrator: SOCRATES of Alopece, son of Sophroniscus

persons in the dialogue:

CHAEREPHON *a close friend of Socrates*

CRITIAS *related to Plato, associated with Socrates*

CHARMIDES *related to Plato, associated with Socrates*

scene: Palaestra of Taureus, near the Royal Stoa

153a

We arrived back yesterday evening from the camp at Potidaea¹, and as I was returning after a long absence, I was delighted to go to my familiar haunts. I went especially to the wrestling school of Taureus, the one opposite the Queen's Shrine, and I came across a lot of people there, most of whom were familiar to me, but there were also some whom I did not know. When they saw me ^{153b} coming in so unexpectedly, they immediately greeted me from all sides, and Chaerephon², being the mad person he is, jumped up in their midst, ran toward me, took me by the hand and said, "Socrates, how did you survive the battle?" A little before we left, there had been a battle at Potidaea which the people here had just heard about. And in reply to him, I said, "Like this, just as you see me."

153c

"Well, it was reported here", said he, "that there had been an extremely fierce battle in which many people we know had died." "And for the most part, that report is true," said I. "Were you actually there in the battle?" he asked. "I was there." "Then sit down here," said he, "and tell us all about it, for we have not yet found out all the details with any clarity." And as he spoke, he led me over and seated me beside Critias³, the son of Callaeschrus. So I sat beside him, greeted Critias and the others, and then gave them a full account of the news from the ^{153d} camp, answering the various questions that each of them asked. Once we had had enough of such stories, I in turn questioned them about the state of affairs here, about the status of

philosophy, and about the young people and whether any of them had proved to be especially notable for wisdom or beauty, or both. Critias glanced over at the door and saw some young men coming in engaged in mutual banter and another group following behind. "Socrates," said he, "as far as the beautiful ones are concerned, I think you will get your answer straight away. Yes, those fellows who are coming in at the moment are leading the way, and they are lovers of the fellow who is regarded, nowadays at any rate, as the most beautiful of them all, and it looks to me as if the lad himself is already nearby." "Who is he," I asked, "and whose son is he?" "I presume you know him," he replied, "although he was not yet of age before you went away. He is Charmides, the son of Glaucon, my uncle, so he is my cousin."

154b

"I know him indeed, by Zeus," said I, "since he was remarkable even when he was still a boy, and I presume at this stage he is already quite a fine young man." "You will know soon enough", said he, "how grown up he is and what he is like." And as he was saying all this, Charmides entered. Now, my friend, do not use me as the measure, for I am a white line on a white surface when it comes to beautiful people, since almost anyone who has come of age looks beautiful to me. Nevertheless, at that moment, the young man looked amazing to me, in stature and in beauty, and ^{154c} all the others seemed to be in love with him, they were so astounded and excited when he entered, and there were lots more lovers following behind too. Now, for men of our age, this response was no great surprise, but I also paid attention to the young boys, and not one of them, not even the smallest of them, so much as glanced at anyone else. No, they all looked at him as though he were a statue. And Chaerephon called out to me, "Socrates, how does this young man look to you," he ^{154d} said, "isn't he fair of face?" "Exceedingly so," said I. "Yet if this fellow were willing to strip," said he, "you would

think he had no face, so utterly beautiful is his physique.” Now, the others all said the same thing as Chaerephon, and I said, “By Heracles, what an indomitable man you are describing if he happens to possess one additional quality, a minor one.” “What?” asked Critias. “If he happens to have a well-developed soul,” said I. “And since he belongs to your family, Critias, ^{154e} that is the sort of person he should presumably be.” “Yes,” said he, “he is very noble and good in that sense too.” “Well, why don’t we strip this particular part of him and look at that, before we look at his body? For I am quite sure that he is now at an age when he is willing to engage in discourse.” “Very much so,” said Critias, “and mark my words, he is also a lover of wisdom, and in the ^{155a} opinion of others, and of himself, quite a poet.” “This, Critias, my friend, is a beauty that belongs in your family from the past through your ancestral connection with Solon. But why don’t you call the young man over and show him to me? For presumably, even if he happened to be younger still, it would not embarrass him to converse with us in your presence, you who are both his guardian and his cousin.” “Yes, that’s a good suggestion, Socrates,” said he, “we will call him.” And with that he said ^{155b} to his attendant, “Boy, call Charmides and say that I want to introduce him to a physician in relation to that ailment he told me he was suffering from yesterday. Then Critias turned to me and explained, “In fact, he said recently that he has a headache when he gets up in the morning, so what is to stop you from pretending to him that you know a remedy for a headache?” “Nothing,” said I, “just let him come over.”

^{155c}

Well, that is what actually happened. Indeed, he arrived and caused a great deal of laughter. For in order to make room for Charmides to sit beside him, each of us who were already seated pushed eagerly against his neighbour until the fellow seated at one end had to stand up, and we knocked the fellow at the other end off sideways. Then Charmides came and sat between myself

and Critias. There and then, my friend, I was already at a loss, and my former confidence was knocked out of me, the confidence that I could converse with him quite easily. But when Critias was explaining ^{155d} that I was the one who knew the remedy, the lad looked into my eyes in a manner that defies description, sat up as if to ask me a question, and everyone in the Palaestra surged all around us in a circle. Then indeed, my noble friend, I beheld the inside of his garment and I was inflamed, and was no longer in myself, and I decided that when it came to love, Cydias was the wisest poet. When speaking of a beautiful boy, he advised someone that ‘the fawn should be careful when he ^{155e} arrives in front of a lion, lest he be seized as a piece of meat.’ Indeed, I thought that I myself had been captured by a creature of this sort. Nevertheless, when he asked if I knew the remedy for the headache, I somehow replied with difficulty that I knew it. “Well, what is it?” he asked. And I replied that it was a certain leaf, but in addition to the remedy there was also a certain incantation, and if a person were to chant this at the same time as he used the remedy, the remedy would make him completely healthy, but without the incantation, the leaf would be of no benefit.

^{156a}

“Then I will write down the incantation. Call it out.” “Shall I do it only if you persuade me,” said I, “or even if you do not?” So he laughed and said, “If I persuade you, Socrates.” “So be it,” said I, “and are you certain of my name?” “Unless I am doing you wrong,” said he, “for amongst my own age group you are talked about quite a lot, and I also remember you associating with Critias here, even when I was a child.”

^{156b}

“Well done,” said I. “Yes, I shall speak more openly to you about the kind of incantation it happens to be. I was at a loss just now as to how I might show you its power, Charmides, for this sort of incantation is unable to make the head alone healthy. Rather,

just as you may already have heard from the good physicians, whenever someone comes to them with sore eyes, they say, somehow, that they cannot attempt to treat the eyes on their own, but it would also be necessary to treat the ^{156c} head at the same time, if the eyes are to be in good condition. And what is more, it is highly irrational to think the head could ever be treated just by itself without treating the whole body. So based on this principle, they endeavour to treat and to cure the part, along with the whole, by regimens applicable to the entire body. Aren't you aware that this is what they say and that this is how matters stand?" "Entirely so," he replied. "In that case, do you think I am expressing this well, and do you accept the principle?" "Without reservation," he replied.

^{156d}

When I heard his approval I recovered my confidence, my courage gradually revived once more, and my spirit was rekindled. I said, "Well, that is the sort of incantation this is, Charmides. I learned it up there on campaign from one of the Thracian physicians of Zalmoxis, who are also said to confer immortality. The Thracian said that Greek physicians who say what I just told you are right ^{156e} to say so. 'But,' said he, 'Zalmoxis, our king, who is a god, says that just as one should not attempt to cure eyes without head, or head without body, so one should not attempt to cure body without curing soul. This is the reason why so many diseases evade the Greek physicians; it is because they disregard the whole, which needs to be cared for, because if the whole is not in good condition it is impossible for the part to be well. For,' said he, 'everything comes forth from the soul, both what is good and what is bad for the body, and for the entire person. These flow from there, just as they flow from the head to the eyes. So it is necessary to treat that first and foremost, if any part ^{157a} of the head or of the rest of the body is to be in a good condition.' And he said, 'Blessed man, the soul is treated with certain incantations, and these incantations

are beautiful words. From such words as these, sound-mindedness is engendered in our souls, and once it has been engendered, and is present, it is easy at that stage to provide health to the head and to the rest of the body too.'

157b

So when teaching me about the remedy and the incantations, he said, 'Let no one who has not first submitted his soul to be treated by you with the incantation, persuade you to treat his head. And, indeed,' said he, 'this is the mistake some physicians make in treating people nowadays; they endeavour to be physicians of sound-mindedness, and of bodily health, separately.' And he commanded me, quite forcibly, to allow no one, no matter how wealthy, well born or handsome he might be, to persuade me to do otherwise. So since I have sworn an oath and it is necessary that I ^{157c} obey it, I shall obey it. As for you, if you wish to follow the orders of the stranger, and first submit your soul to be enchanted by the Thracian charms, I shall then apply the leaf to your head. If not, we do not know what we should do with you, dear Charmides." Now, when Critias heard me saying this, he said, "This headache could turn out to be a godsend for the young man, Socrates, if he will be compelled to improve his thinking because of his head. But, I tell you, Charmides is not regarded as superior to the rest of his age group ^{157d} for his looks alone, but also for the quality for which you claim to have the incantation. You say it is for sound-mindedness, don't you?" "Very much so," I replied. "Well, mark my words," he said, "he is regarded, far and away, as the most sound-minded lad there is nowadays, and in all other respects he is as good as anyone else of that age." "And, indeed, Charmides," said I, "it is only right that you should be superior to the others in all ^{157e} qualities of this sort. Indeed, I do not think anyone else here could so easily point to two families in Athens that, united and combined, are likely to beget more noble and exalted offspring than the families you were born

from. Indeed, your father's family, the family of Critias, son of Dropides, eulogised by Anacreon, Solon and many other poets, has been presented to us as superior in nobility and excellence, and in anything else that counts as happiness. And the same goes for ^{158a} your mother's family, since it is said that no one on the continent was reputed to be a more noble and influential man than your uncle Pyrilampes, when he went on embassies to the Great King or to anyone else on the continent. And this side of your family, in its entirety, is not at all inferior to the other. "So, sprung from such families as these, it is likely that you are foremost in everything. Now, from what we can see of your physique, dear son of Glaucon, I do not think you have fallen ^{158b} below the standard of any of your forebears in any respect, and if you really are naturally endowed with enough sound-mindedness too, and the other qualities our friend here mentioned, then your mother bore a blessed son indeed, dear Charmides. "So this is how matters stand. If, as Critias here says, sound-mindedness is already present in you, and you are sufficiently sound-minded, you no longer have need of the incantations of Zalmoxis or of Abaris the Hyperborean, and you should be given the head remedy straightaway.

^{158c}

But if you seem, as yet, to be deficient in these, you should chant the incantation before you are ^{158d} situation either to admit or deny what he had been asked. "Indeed," said he, "if I say I am not sound-minded, this is not just a strange thing to say against oneself, but at the same time I would be proving Critias here a liar, and many others too who regard me as sound-minded because this man says so. Then again, if I say that I am sound-minded and sing my own praises, that will surely appear offensive. So I do not know how I am to answer you." And I said, "That sounds reasonable to me, Charmides. And in my opinion we should jointly consider whether or not you have acquired what I am asking you about, so that you are not

forced to say what you do not wish to say, nor shall I, for my part, turn my hand to medical treatment without due deliberation. So if it is acceptable to you, I want to consider this along with you. If not, let us leave it.” “Well,” said he, “nothing could be more acceptable. So to that end let’s consider this in whatever manner you yourself think better.” “Then,” said I, “I think our investigation into this is best conducted as follows. Indeed, it is obvious ^{159a} that if sound-mindedness is present in you, you are able to form some opinion about it. For once sound-mindedness is in you, if it is actually in you, it must, I presume, produce a certain awareness from which you would have some opinion about it, as to what sound-mindedness is and what sort of thing it is. Don’t you think so?” “Yes, I think so,” he replied. “In that case,” said I, “since, in fact, you know how to speak Greek, I am sure you could also say what this appears to you to be.” “Perhaps,” said he. “Well, then,” said I, “so that we may hazard a guess as to whether sound-mindedness is in you, or not, you should tell us what you say sound-mindedness is in your opinion.”

^{159b}

Initially he was reluctant and did not really want to answer, but then he said that in his opinion, sound-mindedness is doing everything in an orderly manner and quietly: in walking on the streets, in conversation and doing everything else in a similar fashion. “And in my opinion,” said he, “what you are asking me about is, in short, a certain quietness.” “Well now,” said I, “is this right? People do say, at any rate, that those who are quiet are sound minded, so let us see if they have a point. Tell me then, wouldn’t you say sound-mindedness is something good?” “Entirely so,” he replied. “Well, for the writing teacher, is it best to write similar letters quickly or quietly?” “Quickly.” “And what about reading? Is it good to do so quickly or quietly?” “Quickly.” “Yes, and are playing the harp quickly, and wrestling⁵ nimbly, much better than doing so quietly and

slowly?” “Yes.” “What about boxing and the pankration? Isn’t the situation the same?” “Entirely so.”

159d

“In running and jumping too, and in all activities of the body, aren’t those that occur nimbly and quickly the good ones, while those that are done with difficulty and quietly the bad ones?” “Apparently.” “Then it is apparent to us that what is best, in the case of the body at any rate, is not what is quietest but what is quickest and nimblest. Is this so?” “Entirely so.” “And was sound-mindedness something good?” “Yes.” “Then, in the case of the body at least, not quietness but quickness would be more sound-minded, since sound-mindedness is something good.” “So it seems,” said he. “What about this?” said I. “Which is better, ease of learning or difficulty in learning?”

159e

“Ease of learning.” “And does ease of learning involve learning quickly, while difficulty in learning involves learning quietly and slowly?” “Yes.” “And isn’t it better to teach someone else quickly and energetically rather than quietly and slowly?” “Yes.” “What about this? Is it better to recollect and to remember quietly and slowly or energetically and quickly?” “Energetically and quickly,” he replied. “And isn’t quick-wittedness a certain nimbleness of the soul, rather than a quietness?”

160a

“True.” “And for the writing teacher and harp teacher or anyone else, isn’t it best to understand what is said, not as quietly as possible but as quickly as possible?” “Yes.” “Then again, in the investigations of the soul and in deliberation, it is not the quietest person, I think, or the one who deliberates and makes discoveries with difficulty, who seems to be worthy of praise, but the one who does this most easily and quickly.”

160b

“This is so,” he said. “Therefore, Charmides,” said I, “in actions, whether they concern the soul or the body, do those that are quickest and nimblest appear nobler to us than those that are slowest and quietest?” “Quite likely,” said he. “So sound-mindedness would not be quietness, nor would the sound-minded life be quiet, at least on the basis of this argument, since it must be good if it is sound-minded. And so, there are two possibilities: either there are no circumstances where quiet actions in life are better than quick and ^{160c} vigorous ones, or there are very few. But, my friend, even if it is the case that just as many quiet actions as vigorous and quick ones happen to be good, not even on this basis would sound-mindedness consist more in acting quietly than in acting energetically and quickly, either in walking, in talking, or in anything else. Nor would the quiet orderly life be more sound-minded than the ^{160d} one that is not quiet. This is because, in our argument, we included sound-mindedness with the good, yet the quick actions have turned out to be no less good than the quiet ones.” “I think, Socrates,” said he, “that what you have said is correct.” “Then, Charmides,” said I, “once again, pay even closer attention to yourself, look into yourself, reflect upon the sort of person sound-mindedness makes you by its presence, and what it must be like in order to produce such an effect, and once you have drawn your conclusions from all this, declare nicely and courageously what does it appear to you to be?”

^{160e}

And he paused, scrutinised himself very courageously and said, “Well, it seems to me that sound-mindedness makes a person ashamed and produces modesty, and modesty is what sound-mindedness actually is.” “Well,” said I, “didn’t we agree just now that sound-mindedness is something good?” “Entirely so,” he replied. “And aren’t the sound-minded men also good?” “Yes.” “Now, could something that does not produce good men

be good?" "Of course not." "So sound-mindedness is not only noble, it is also good."

161a

"Yes, I think so." "What is this?" said I. "Don't you believe Homer when he says 'Modesty is not a good companion for a needy man'?"¹⁰ "I do," said he. "So modesty is, it seems, both not good and good." "Apparently." "And yet, sound-mindedness is good if its presence really does make people good and not bad." "Why, yes, I think that is how matters stand, just as you say."

161b

"Then sound-mindedness would not be modesty since it actually happens to be good, while modesty is no more good than bad." "Well, Socrates, it seems to me that what you are saying is correct, but consider this, what do you think of the following statement about sound-mindedness? Indeed, I have just remembered hearing someone say that sound-mindedness would be 'doing what belongs to yourself'. Now, consider whether the person who said this was correct in saying so, in your opinion."

161c

"You wretch," said I, "you have heard this from Critias here, or from someone else who is wise." "It seems he heard it from someone else," said Critias, "since it certainly was not from me." "Socrates, what difference does it make from whom I heard it?" said Charmides. "None," I replied, "for we should not really consider who said this, but whether what is being said is true or not." "Now you are speaking aright," said he. "Yes, by Zeus," said I, "but if we find out what it means I would be surprised, for it seems like some sort of riddle." "Why is that?" he asked.

161d

"Because the speaker," said I, "in saying that sound-mindedness is doing what belongs to you, did not intend the words in the way that he expressed them. Or do you think the writing

teacher does nothing whenever he writes or reads?” “No,” he replied, “I think he does something.” “So, do you think the grammar teacher only writes and reads his own name or teaches you boys to do this too? Or did you write the names of your enemies no less than those of yourselves and your friends?” “No less.” “Well, in this respect, were you being a busybody and not being sound-minded in doing so?”

161e

“Not at all.” “And yet, you were not doing what belongs to yourselves if writing and reading is ‘doing something’.” “And so they are.” “And, indeed, my friend, healing, housebuilding, weaving, or performing any of the tasks of a skill, by any skill whatsoever, is presumably ‘doing something’.” “Entirely so.” “What about this? Do you think a city would be well administered under this law, calling upon each person to weave and wash his own garment, to cobble his own shoes, make his own oil-flask and scraper, and everything else, on the same principle: that each person should not touch what belongs to others but work at, and do, what belongs to himself?”

162a

“No, I do not think so,” he replied. “And yet,” said I, “the city that is administered sound-mindedly would be well administered.” “How could it not be?” said he. “So, performing actions of this sort, and doing what belongs to you in this way, would not be sound-mindedness,” said I. “Apparently not.” “So, the person who said that doing what belongs to yourself is sound-mindedness was, it seems, speaking a riddle, as I said just now. For I presume he was not quite so simple-minded. Or did you ^{162b} hear some foolish fellow saying this, Charmides?” “Far from it,” he replied. “In fact, he seemed to be extremely wise.” “Well then, I am of the opinion, to an even greater extent, that he posed a riddle as to the difficulty of recognising what exactly ‘doing what belongs to yourself’ is.” “Perhaps,” said he. “Well, what exactly would ‘doing what belongs to yourself’ be? Can

you say?" "By Zeus, I do not know," he replied, "but perhaps even the person who said this did not know what he intended." And as he said this he smiled and glanced over at Critias. Now, Critias had obviously been quite agitated for some time, and, being eager to impress ^{162c} Charmides and the company, he had restrained himself with difficulty in the previous discussion, but at this stage he was unable to do so. Indeed, the suspicion I held now seemed to be all the more true, that Charmides had heard this answer about sound-mindedness from Critias. So Charmides, who did not wish to furnish an account of the answer himself, but wanted Critias to do so instead, kept stirring up Critias, and pointing out that he himself had been refuted. But Critias could not ^{162d} bear this. Rather, he seemed to me to be angry with Charmides, just like a poet with an actor who recites his compositions badly. So he looked at him and said, "Charmides, do you really think that if you do not know what exactly the person who said that sound-mindedness is 'doing what belongs to yourself' intended, the man himself did not know either?" "But Critias, best of men," said I, "it is no surprise that he does not understand this at his ^{162e} age. But I expect you are likely to know on account of your age and your experience. So if you concur that sound-mindedness is what this fellow says it is, and you take over the argument, I would much prefer to investigate along with you whether the statement is true or not." "Yes, I concur, emphatically, and I am taking over," he said. "Well, you are acting quite nobly," said I. "Tell me then, do you also concur about what I was asking just now, that all craftsmen make something?" "I do." "Now, do they seem to you to make only what belongs to themselves, or also what belongs to ^{163a} others?" "What belongs to others too." "So are they being sound-minded, even though they are not making only what belongs to themselves?" "Is there any reason why not?" he replied. "None, for me at least," said I. "But look, there may be one for the man who proposes that soundmindedness is

‘doing what belongs to oneself’, and then says there is no reason why those who ^{163b} “Tell me,” said I, “don’t you call making and doing the same?” “I certainly do not,” he replied. “Nor working and making either, for I learned from Hesiod who said that ‘work is no disgrace’. But do you actually think that if he called the sort of works you referred to just now, ‘working’ and ‘doing’, he could accept that there is no disgrace in someone being a cobbler, a fishmonger or a prostitute? Don’t you believe it, ^{163c} Socrates. No, this man too, in my opinion, considered ‘making’ as other than ‘doing’ and ‘working’, and although something one makes is sometimes a disgrace whenever it is not accompanied by nobility, no work is ever a disgrace. For whatever is made nobly and beneficially, these he called works, and he referred to ‘makings’ of this sort as ‘workings’ and ‘doings’. And we should say that he believed that the like of these alone are kindred to us, while those that are harmful are all alien. And so we should presume that Hesiod, and any other man of understanding, calls the person doing what belongs to himself, sound-minded.”

^{163d}

“Critias,” said I, “I understood your argument almost as soon as you began, that you call what is kindred to us and what belongs to ourselves, good, and you call the ‘makings’ of the good people, ‘doings.’ And, indeed, I have heard Prodicus drawing thousands of such distinctions about words. Well, I allow you to employ each of the words in any way you wish, only please make clear in every case what you are applying the name to. So now, once more, from the beginning, define this ^{163e} more clearly. The doing or making, or however you wish to name it, of what is good, is this what you say sound-mindedness is?” “I do,” he replied. “So, the person who does what is bad is not sound-minded, but the person who does what is good, is.” “Best of men,” said he, “isn’t this how it seems to you?” “Never mind that,” said I. “Let us not consider my opinion at this stage, but

what you are now saying.” “Well then, I deny,” said he, “that someone who makes what is not good, but bad, is soundminded. Rather, someone who makes what is good, but not bad, is sound-minded. For I am defining sound-mindedness in plain terms for you, as doing what is good.”

164a

“And there is, perhaps,” said I, “no reason why you should not be speaking the truth. Yet I am wondering if you think sound-minded people are unaware of being sound-minded.” “No, I do not think so,” he replied. “Didn’t you say a little earlier,” I asked, “that there is no reason why craftsmen, even those who make what belongs to others, cannot be sound-minded?” “Yes, I said so,” he replied. “What of it?”

164b

“Nothing, but please tell me whether you think a physician, when making someone healthy, makes something that is beneficial both to himself and to the person he treats?” “I think so.” “Isn’t someone who is doing this, doing what is needed?” “Yes.” “Isn’t someone who is doing what is needed, sound-minded?” “Sound-minded, indeed.” “Now, is it also necessary for the physician to recognise when he is applying the treatment beneficially and when he is not, and for each of the craftsmen to recognise when he is going to gain an advantage from the work he is doing, and when not?” “Perhaps not.” “In that case,” said I, “having done something beneficially, or harmfully, the physician sometimes 164c does not recognise, himself, how he has done it, even though according to your argument, in doing it beneficially he has done it sound-mindedly. Isn’t this how you put it?” “I did.” “And so it seems, in doing something beneficially, even though he does it sound-mindedly and is sound-minded, he is sometimes unaware, himself, of being sound-minded.” “But, Socrates,” said he, “this could never happen, and if you think that anything I accepted earlier leads necessarily to this conclusion, I would

rather retract anything, and I would ^{164d} not be ashamed to say I had been wrong, rather than ever concede that a person who is, himself, unaware of himself, is sound-minded. Indeed, I would almost declare that this is just what sound-mindedness is, recognising oneself, and I go along with whomsoever set up such an inscription in Delphi. In fact, I think this inscription was set up in this way as an actual salutation by the god to those who enter, instead of 'Hail', because this saluta- ^{164e} tion, 'Hail', is not right, nor should we exhort one another to this, but to 'Be soundminded.' So the god addresses those who enter the temple in this way somewhat differently from the way we humans do, and whoever set up the inscription had this in mind, in my opinion. And to anyone who ever enters, he says just one thing, 'Be sound-minded'. And, indeed, he speaks somewhat enigmatically, like a seer, for 'Know Thyself' and 'be sound-minded' are the same as the inscription declares, and so do I. But someone could ^{165a} presume that they are different, and I think that is what happened to those who dedicated the later inscriptions 'Nothing in Excess' and 'Give a Pledge and Ruin is Nigh'. In fact, these men thought that 'Know Thyself' was a piece of advice rather than a salutation by the god for the sake of those who enter the temple. Accordingly, they dedicated these inscriptions so that they could offer advice that was every bit as useful. "Now then, Socrates, the reason why I am saying all this is as follows. I am retracting everything that was said previously; perhaps you said something on these issues that was ^{165b} more correct, perhaps I did, but nothing we were saying was particularly clear. Yet I am prepared now to present you with an argument for this, if you still do not accept that soundmindedness is recognising your own self." "But Critias," said I, "you are addressing me as if I profess to have knowledge of the issues I am asking you about, and could agree with you if I wanted to, but that is not how matters stand. No, in fact, I am investigating anything that is ever put forward, along with you,

because I myself do not know. So I am prepared to say whether I accept, or do not accept, once I have considered this, ^{165c} but please wait until I consider it.” “Consider it then,” said he. “Yes, indeed,” said I, “I am considering it. Well, if sound-mindedness is recognising something, it would obviously be a knowledge, and a knowledge of something, wouldn’t it?” “It would,” said he. “Of yourself.” “Isn’t medicine knowledge of health?” I asked. “Entirely so.” “Then,” said I, “if you were to ask me, ‘since medicine is knowledge of health, what use is it to us and what does it bring about?’ I would reply that it is a considerable benefit, since it brings about ^{165d} health, a good outcome for us, if you accept this.” “I accept this.” “Then if you should also ask me, ‘since housebuilding is the knowledge of building houses, what outcome do I say it produces?’, I would say, ‘houses’, and the same goes for the other skills. Now, ^{166a} products of various skills that one could point to? Well, are you also able to point out an outcome of this kind to me in these two cases? No, you will not be able to do so.” “And,” I replied, “what you say is true, but I am able to point out to you something that each of these knowledges is knowledge of, something that happens to be other than the knowledge itself. For example, calculation is presumably of the even and the odd, how they relate to themselves and to one another in quantity. Is this so?” “Very much so,” he replied. “Aren’t the even and the odd different from calculation itself?” “How could they not be?”

^{166b}

“Then again, although weighing is weighing of the heavier and lighter weight, the heavy and the light are different from weighing itself. Do you agree?” “I do.” “Then state what it is that sound-mindedness is knowledge of, something that happens to be different from sound-mindedness itself.” “That is my point, Socrates,” said he. “You arrive in your enquiry at the very thing that distinguishes sound-mindedness from all the knowledges, but now you are investigating some ^{166c} likeness to

the others. But that is not how matters stand. Rather, although all the others are knowledge of another, but not of themselves, this one, alone, is knowledge of the other knowledges and of itself. And this has not escaped your notice, far from it. No, I think you are now doing what you denied you were doing just now; you are just trying to refute me, and you have abandoned the issue that the argument is concerned with.” “What an assumption to make,” said I, “that if I am refuting you, as best I can, I am refuting you ^{166d} from any other motive than the very motive from which I would also scrutinise what I myself am saying, for fear that I might ever, unwittingly, be thinking I know something when I do not know. And so I now declare that this is what I am doing: considering the argument, most of all for the sake of myself, but also perhaps for my other companions. Or don’t you think it is a good, common to almost all of humanity, that each of the things that are comes to be seen clearly just as it is?” “I do, Socrates,” said he, “very much so.” “Then, blessed man, be bold in answering the question, based on how it appears to you, and never ^{166e} mind whether it is Critias or Socrates who is being refuted. Just apply your mind to the argument itself and consider how exactly it turns out under scrutiny.” “Yes,” said he, “that’s what I’ll do, since what you are saying sounds reasonable to me.” “Then,” said I, “explain. What are you saying about sound-mindedness?” “Well,” said he, “I am saying that of all the other knowledges, it alone is knowledge, both of itself and the other knowledges.” “In that case,” said I, “wouldn’t it also be knowledge of lack of knowledge, if it is indeed knowledge of knowledge?” “Entirely so,” he said.

^{167a}

“So only the sound-minded man will, himself, recognise himself, and will be able to examine what he happens to know, and not know. And, in like manner, he will have the power to determine what other people know and think they know, and what he himself thinks he knows but does not know. No one else

will be able to do this. And this is what being sound-minded and sound-mindedness, and recognising one's own self, actually are – knowing what one knows and what one does not know. So, is this what you mean?" "I do," he replied. "Then, once more," said I, 'the third time for the Saviour', as if we were starting anew, let us first ^{167b} consider whether something like this is possible or not: knowing that one knows, and that one does not know, what one knows and what one does not know. And secondly, if this is at all possible, let us consider what benefit we would derive from knowing this." "Yes," said he, "we should consider this." "Come on then, Critias," said I, "let us see if you turn out to be more resourceful than I am in dealing with these matters. For I am actually perplexed. Shall I tell you why I am perplexed?" "Yes, certainly," he said. "Well," said I, "if it is as you were just saying it is, wouldn't all these be a single knowledge, which is not knowledge of anything else except itself and the other knowledges? And what is more, this ^{167c} same knowledge is knowledge of lack of knowledge." "Entirely so." "Do you see, my friend, how strange the assertion we are trying to make actually is? For in other cases, if you consider them, the same situation will, I think, surely seem impossible to you." "In what way and in what cases?" "In the following cases. Indeed, you need to decide if, in your opinion, there is some seeing which is not a seeing of whatever the other seeings are seeings of, but is, rather, a seeing of itself and the other seeings, and of lack of seeing too, in like manner. And even though it is a seeing, it sees no colour, just itself and the other seeings. Does there seem to you to be such a seeing?"

^{167d}

"By Zeus, not to me." "And what about hearing that does not hear a single sound, but does hear itself, and the other hearings, and lack of hearing?" "No, not this either." "Then, to sum up, in the case of all the sense perceptions, consider whether in your opinion there is any perception that is perception of

perceptions and of itself, whilst perceiving nothing of what the other perceptions perceive.” “It doesn’t seem so to me, at any rate.” “Well, do you think there is any desire that is not a desire for any pleasure at all, but for itself and ^{167e} the other desires?” “Of course not.” “Nor indeed, I presume, is there a wish that wishes for nothing good, but does wish for itself and the other wishes.” “Indeed not.” “And would you say that there is a kind of love that happens to be a love of nothing noble, but is love of itself and the other loves?” “Not I,” he replied. “And have you ever observed any fear that fears itself and the other fears, but does not fear anything ^{168a} dreadful at all?” “I have not observed one,” he replied. “Or an opinion that is an opinion of opinions and of itself, but forms an opinion of nothing that the others form opinions of?” “Not at all.” “But we are saying, it seems, that there is some knowledge that is of this kind, one that although it is knowledge of nothing that is learned, is yet a knowledge of itself and the other knowledges.” “We are saying so, indeed.” “But if it turns out that there really is such a knowledge, isn’t it strange? Indeed, we should not yet affirm, definitely, that there is not, rather we should still consider whether there is such knowledge.”

^{168b}

“Correct.” “Come on then, this knowledge is knowledge of something, and it possesses a power of this kind so as to be ‘of something’. Isn’t this so?” “Entirely so.” “And, indeed, we say the greater possesses a power of this kind, so as to be greater ‘than something’.” “It possesses it, indeed.” “If indeed it is to be greater, won’t it be greater than something lesser?” “Necessarily.” “Now, if we were to discover some greater that is greater than the ‘greater’ and than itself, but ^{168c} greater than nothing that the other ‘greater’ are greater than, presumably it would be entirely in the situation whereby if it were indeed greater than itself, it would also be less than itself, wouldn’t it?” “Necessarily, Socrates, very much so.” “What is more, if

something is a double of the other doubles, and of itself, then being a double of the others, and of itself, it would then of course be a half, for a double is presumably double of nothing other than a half.” “True.” “Won’t, then, what is more than itself also be less than itself; what is heavier, lighter; what is older, ^{168d} younger; and in the same way in all other cases, won’t whatever has the power of itself, directed towards itself, also possess the being towards which its power was directed? I mean something like the following: we say that hearing, for instance, would be hearing of nothing else except sound. Is this so?” “Yes.” “In that case, if hearing is indeed to hear itself, it will hear itself as possessing sound, for otherwise it would not hear.” “Most necessarily.” “Seeing too, I presume, best of men, if it is indeed to see itself, needs itself to possess some colour, ^{168e} for seeing could never see anything devoid of colour.” “Indeed it could not.” “Well, Critias, do you see that so far, in working through this, in some cases it appears absolutely impossible to us, and in other cases barely credible that they have the power of themselves directed towards themselves? In fact, in the case of magnitude and quantity and the like, it is absolutely impossible, isn’t it?” “Entirely so.” “Then again, hearing and seeing, and even motion itself moving itself, and heat burning itself, and ^{169a} all other cases of this sort, would be met with incredulity by some, but perhaps not by others. So, my friend, there is a need for some great man who will determine satisfactorily, in all cases, whether none of the things that are, have by nature the power of themselves directed towards themselves rather than something else, or whether some do and others do not. And if there are cases where their power is directed towards themselves, is there among them a knowledge which we declare to be sound-mindedness? Therefore, I do not trust myself to be up to the task of affirming any of ^{169b} this, either that this can happen that there is a knowledge of knowledge or, even if there really is, I cannot accept that this is

sound-mindedness until I consider whether something like this would benefit us or not, for I actually have a presentiment that sound-mindedness is something beneficial and good. So, son of Callaeschrus, since you propose that sound-mindedness is knowledge of knowledge, and indeed of lack of knowledge, you should first show that what I was just speaking of is possible, and then, that as well as being possible, is also beneficial, and you will, perhaps, ^{169c} satisfy me that what you are saying about what sound-mindedness is is correct.” Well, when Critias had heard all this and saw how perplexed I was, then, like people who see others yawning in front of them and do the same thing themselves, he seemed to me to have been forced by my perplexity and been overcome by perplexity himself. Now, since he was a man with an enduring reputation, he felt ashamed before the company and was unwilling to accept my point that he was incapable of making the distinctions I was asking him to make, and to hide his per- ^{169d} plexity he did not say anything definite. So in order that our argument might proceed, I said, “But, Critias, if you like, let us accept for now that there can be a knowledge of knowledge, and we shall consider on another occasion whether this is indeed the case or not. Come on then, if this is entirely possible, is it any more possible to know what one knows, and does not know? Since surely, according to us, this is recognising yourself, and being sound-minded. Is this so?” “Entirely so,” said he. “I presume that follows at least. For if someone has knowledge that ^{169e} itself recognises itself, such a person would be just like what he possesses; just as when someone possesses speed, he is fast; when someone possesses beauty, he is beautiful; and when he possesses recognition, he recognises; and when someone possesses recognition of recognition itself, he will then, presumably, be recognising his own self.” “I am not”, said I, “disputing the contention that whenever someone possesses that which recognises itself, he himself will recognise his own self, but why it is necessary for

someone who possesses this to know what he knows and what he does not know.” “Because, Socrates, this is the same as that.”

170a

“Perhaps,” said I, “but I am afraid I am still as confused as ever, for I do not understand how knowing what one knows, and knowing what someone does not know, are the same as self-knowledge.” “What do you mean?” he asked. “As follows,” I replied. “Assuming that there is knowledge of knowledge, will it be able to do anything more than make a distinction whereby, of these two, this is knowledge and this is not knowledge?” “No, that is the extent of it.” “Now, are knowledge and lack of knowledge of health, and knowledge and lack of knowledge of 170b justice, the same?” “Not at all.” “No. One, I believe, is medicine, the other is statesmanship, while knowledge is nothing other than knowledge.” “How could it not be?” “What if someone were not to have the additional knowledge of health and justice, but recognised knowledge alone? Since he had knowledge of this alone, he would be likely to recognise merely that he has knowledge of something, and that he has some knowledge concerning himself and concerning the others too. Is this so?” “Yes.” “But how will he recognise what he knows by means of this knowledge? For he recognises what 170c is healthy by medicine, but not by sound-mindedness, and what is harmonious by music, but not by sound-mindedness, and housebuilding by construction, but not by sound-mindedness, and the same goes for them all. Isn’t this so?”

170d

“So being sound-minded would not be this – knowing what one knows and what one does not know – but only, it seems, knowing that one knows and that one does not know.” “Quite likely.” “Nor will this person be able to examine whether someone else who claims to know something, knows or does not know what he claims to know. Rather, it seems, he will only recognise that the man has some knowledge, but

sound-mindedness will not enable him to recognise what the knowledge is knowledge of.” “Apparently not.”

170e

“So he will not be able to judge who is pretending to be a physician when he is not, and who is truly so, nor who else is knowledgeable and who is not. Let us consider it as follows: if the soundminded person or anyone else at all is going to recognise who truly is a physician and who is not, there is something he will not do, he will surely not discuss medicine with him, for the physician as we said has knowledge of nothing except health and disease. Isn’t that so?” “Yes, just so.” “And yet he knows nothing about knowledge, since we assigned this to sound-mindedness alone.” “Yes.”

171a

“Then the physician knows nothing about medicine, since medicine happens to be knowledge.” “True.” “So the sound-minded person will recognise that the physician has some knowledge, but if it is necessary to apprehend what it is, won’t he need to consider what it is knowledge of? Or isn’t each knowledge defined by this, not only as knowledge, but also as a particular knowledge, by being knowledge of certain things?” “By this. Yes, indeed.” “And medicine, then, is defined as different from other knowledges by being knowledge of health and disease.” “Yes.”

171b

“Doesn’t someone who wishes to consider medicine need to consider it in respect of the things it is concerned with, not of course in respect of the things it is not concerned with, that is, in respect of what is external to it?” “Of course not.” “So anyone considering this aright will investigate how the physician is a physician in relation to cases of health and disease.” “So it seems.” “Won’t he do so by considering whether what is said or done in these cases is spoken truly, and done correctly?” “Necessarily.” “Now, would someone without medical

knowledge be able to follow up on either of these?” “Not at all.”

171c

“Then it seems no one else, except the physician, could do so, certainly not the sound-minded man, for in that case, in addition to his sound-mindedness, he would be a physician.” “That is the case.” “So it is all the more evident that if sound-mindedness is knowledge only of knowledge and of lack of knowledge, it will be unable to distinguish between a physician who is knowledgeable in respect of that skill, and one who is not knowledgeable, yet pretends to be such, or thinks he is such, nor anyone else who is knowledgeable in any matter at all, apart from someone with a similar skill to his own, as in the case with other practitioners.” “Apparently so,” he said. “Well then, Critias,” said I, “if sound-mindedness is like this, what benefit might we still derive 171d from it? For if, as we have been proposing all along, the sound-minded person knows what he knows and knows that he knows this, and knows what he does not know and knows that he does not know this, and he is able to investigate this same state of affairs in someone else, then we affirm that it would be of enormous benefit for us to be sound-minded. For we would live out our life free from error; we, and those who possess sound-mindedness, and anyone else who comes under our rule. Nor indeed would we attempt to do things we did not have knowledge of. Rather 171e we would find people who were knowledgeable and hand matters over to them. Nor would we trust others who had come under our rule to do anything else, apart from what they were going to do in the right way, and this would be something they had knowledge of. And in this way, under sound-mindedness a household will be nobly managed, a city nobly governed, and so on for anything else that sound-mindedness might rule over. For with error eliminated and correctness in the 172a ascendant, people in this situation necessarily fare nobly and well in everything they do, and those who fare well are blessed. Well, isn’t this how we

were speaking about sound-mindedness, Critias, when explaining the extent to which knowing what one knows and does not know would be good?" "Yes, certainly, that is how." "But now you see," said I, "that no knowledge anywhere has proved to be like this." "I see," he said. "Well, then," I asked, "does sound-mindedness, which we are now discovering to be knowledge ^{172b} of knowledge and its absence, possess this good? Will someone who possesses this learn whatever else he learns more easily, and will everything appear to him in greater clarity, since in addition to the particular thing he learns, he will also behold the knowledge? And will he better scrutinise others about what he himself has learned, while those who conduct the scrutiny in the absence of this will do so in a less effective and inferior manner? So, my friend, are these the sorts of benefits we ^{172c} shall derive from sound-mindedness, or are we looking upon it as something greater, and requiring it to be something greater than it actually is?" "That may very well be the situation," he replied. "Perhaps," said I, "and perhaps we investigated nothing useful. My evidence is the fact that if it is like this, some strange things about sound-mindedness are becoming plain to me. Indeed, let us look at it, if you wish, by conceding that it is possible to have knowledge of knowledge, and let us not withdraw what we proposed at the outset, that sound-mindedness is knowing what one knows, ^{172d} and what one does not know. Let us accept this. And having accepted all this, let us consider, even better, whether it will actually benefit us at all, if it is like this. For I do not think we were right in agreeing just now that sound-mindedness would be a great good when presiding over the management of households and cities, if it were like this." "How so?" he asked. "Because," said I, "we agreed quite readily that it would be an enormous good for humanity if each of us were to do what he knows, and were to hand over what he does not know to others who are knowledgeable." "Well," said he, "were we not right to agree to

this?”

172e

“I do not think we were,” said I. “What you are saying is truly strange, Socrates,” said he. “Yes, by the dog,” said I, “that is how it seems to me too. And when I noticed this at the time, and just now, I said that strange things were dawning upon me and that I was afraid that we might not ^{173a} be considering this aright. For in truth, if sound-mindedness really is like this, it is not at all obvious to me that it produces any good for us.” “How so?” said he. “Speak, so that we too may understand what you mean.” “Although I think I am talking nonsense,” said I, “nevertheless it is necessary at least to consider what is dawning upon us and not pass on aimlessly, if one cares about oneself even a little.” “Yes, well expressed,” said he. “Then hear my dream,” said I, “whether it has come through horn or through ivory. For if soundmindedness, being as we are now defining it, were to rule us as much as possible, everything would ^{173b} surely be done based upon knowledge, and no one claiming to be a pilot when he is not could deceive us, nor could a physician, a general, or anyone else pretending to know something he does not know, go undetected. Then under these circumstances, what other outcome could there be for us except that our bodies be healthy, more so than now, that we be safe amid the perils of the sea ^{173c} and of warfare, and that all our equipment, our clothes, our shoes, and everything we make use of, and much else besides, be made for us in a more skilful manner through recourse to true practitioners? And if you wish, let us also concede that divination is knowledge of what is to come, and that sound-mindedness, when presiding over this, will turn away the pretenders and install the true diviners for us as prophets of what is to come. I accept that the human race, equipped in this way, ^{173d} would act and live knowledgeably, since sound-mindedness, acting as guardian, would not allow lack of knowledge to creep in and work alongside us. But we are

not yet able to understand that by acting knowledgeably, we would act well and would be blessed, my friend, Critias.” “And yet,” said he, “you will not easily find some other end of acting well if you reject acting knowledgeably.” “Well,” said I, “besides this, teach me a little more. ‘Knowledgeably’ of what? Do you mean of shoemaking?”

173e

“By Zeus! No!” “Of brassworking then?” “Not at all.” “Of wool then, or of wood, or something else of this sort?” “Of course not.” “In that case,” said I, “we are no longer abiding by the statement that someone living knowledgeably is happy. For you do not accept that these people, although they live knowledgeably, are happy. No, you seem to me to define the man who is happy as living knowledgeably in particular respects. And perhaps you are referring to the man I just spoke of, the one who knows all that is ^{174a} to come, the diviner. Are you referring to this man, or to someone else?” “I am referring,” said he, “both to this man and to someone else.” “To whom?” I asked. “Isn’t it someone like this, someone who, in addition to all that is to come and all that has come to be, might also know all that now is, and might be ignorant of nothing? Let us propose that there is such a man. Indeed, I do not think you would say that anyone alive is more knowledgeable than this.” “Of course not.” “Well, I am longing to know this besides: which of the knowledges makes him happy, or are they all alike in this respect?” “No, they are not at all alike,” he replied.

174b

“Then what particular sort of knowledge is it? Among things that are, and things that have come to be, and things that will come to be, this is the knowledge by which we know what? Well, is it the knowledge by which I know draughts-playing?” “What? Draughts-playing!” said he. “Is it calculation then?” “Not at all.” “Is it health then?” “More so,” he replied. “The particular knowledge I am referring to is the one by which we

know what?" "That by which we know the good and the bad," said he. "You wretch!" said I. "You have been dragging me around in a circle all the time, concealing the fact that it is not living knowledgeably that makes us do well and be happy, not even knowledge ^{174c} of all the other knowledges together, but this one knowledge alone, the one concerned with the good and the bad. So, Critias, if you are prepared to take this knowledge away from the other knowledges, will medicine make us healthy any the less, or shoe-making make shoes, or weaving make clothes any the less, or piloting prevent us from dying at sea, or generalship from dying in battle, any the less?" "No less," said he. "But, friend Critias, in the absence of this knowledge, we lose out on having each of these tasks done well and beneficially."

^{174d}

"That is true." "And yet this knowledge, it seems, is not sound-mindedness, but a knowledge whose function is to benefit us. For it is not the knowledge of knowledges and their lack, but of good and bad, and so, if this is beneficial, then sound-mindedness would be something else for us." "But why would this knowledge not be beneficial? For if sound-mindedness really is knowledge of knowledges, it also presides over the other knowledges, and would surely be of ^{174e} benefit to us by ruling over this knowledge concerning the good." "And would this knowledge make us healthy," said I, "and would medicine not do so? And would this perform the other functions belonging to the other skills, and would each of them not perform its own function? Or didn't we affirm some time ago that it is the knowledge of knowledges and of lack of knowledge alone, and of nothing else? Isn't this so?" "Yes, apparently." "Then it will not be an artificer of health, will it?" "Of course not." "For health belonged to a different skill, didn't it?"

^{175a}

“To a different one, yes.” “Nor is it an artificer of benefit, my friend, for again we assigned this function to another skill just now, didn’t we?” “Yes, certainly.” “How then will sound-mindedness be beneficial when it is not the artificer of a single benefit?” “It is not beneficial at all, Socrates, so it seems at least.” “Do you see, Critias, that I had good reason for my fears a while ago, and that I was justified in accusing myself of not considering anything useful in relation to sound-mindedness? For presumably, what is agreed to be the noblest thing of all would not have appeared to be devoid of benefit ^{175b} to us, if I had been of any use in conducting a proper investigation. But now we have the worst of it in every way, and we are not able to discover to which of the things that are, the lawgiver ever gave this name, sound-mindedness. “What is more, much of what we have conceded does not follow from our argument. In fact, we conceded that there is knowledge of knowledge, even though the argument does not allow ^{175c} conceded that this knowledge also recognises the functions of the other knowledges so that our sound-minded person might be knowledgeable of what he knows and what he does not know, that he knew the one and did not know the other. And although we conceded this in an altogether highminded manner, just because our own agreement states that he knows the things that he does not know, we did not investigate the impossibility of someone, somehow or other, knowing what he does not know at all, and yet I think nothing could appear more irrational than this. But nevertheless, the investigation, having found us so simplistic and malleable, is still no more capable of discovering the truth. Rather, it laughs at truth to such an extent that although we have for some time been coming to an agreement and developing a proposition that this is what sound-mindedness is, it revealed to us, very contemptuously, that this is of no benefit. “Now, although I am less concerned for myself, I am very concerned for you,

Charmides,”

175e

said I, “if you, with a body like this and a very sound-minded soul besides, will not profit from this sound-mindedness, and its presence will be of no benefit to you in life. And I am even more concerned for the incantation I learned from the Thracian, if I have learned it with great eagerness when it is something of no value. Now, I do not think this is actually how matters stand. I think, rather, that I am a poor investigator, since sound-mindedness is a great good, and if you do indeed 176a possess it, you are fortunate. But see if you do possess it and have no need of the incantation. For if you possess it, I should advise you rather to presume that I am a babbler, unable to investigate any argument whatsoever, while you yourself, being more sound-minded, are also happier to that extent.” And Charmides said, “By Zeus, Socrates, I do not know whether I possess this or not.

176b

Indeed, how could I know when you say the two of you are unable to discover what precisely it is? However, I am not entirely persuaded by you, Socrates, and I think I myself am much in need of the incantation, and for my own part there is no reason why I should not hear the incantation from you, day after day, until you say I have had enough.” “So be it,” said Critias, “but Charmides, if you do this it will prove, at least to me, that you are sound-minded if you submit to Socrates to hear the incantation, and are not found wanting in this to any extent whatsoever.”

176c

“You may presume that I shall follow him,” he said, “and not be found wanting. For I would be acting terribly if I were to disregard you, my guardian, and not do what you told me to do.” “Well, then,” said Critias, “I am telling you to do so.” “Then I shall do so,” he said, “beginning this very day.” “What are you

two planning to do?" I asked. "Nothing," said Charmides, "we have done our planning." "So are you going to use force and not grant me a preliminary hearing?" I asked. "You may presume that I shall use force since this man here has ordered me to. You, for your part, should plan what you will do in response to this."

176d

"But that leaves no room for any plan at all," said I, "for when the two of you undertake a course of action and do so by force, there is no man alive who will be able to oppose you." "Then you should not oppose us either," said he. "Then," said I, "I shall not oppose you."

NOTES

1. Potidaea was the site of a famous battle during the Peloponnesian War.
2. Chaerephon was Socrates' close friend, who famously asked the oracle at Delphi whether there was anyone wiser than Socrates (Apology 21a). He appears in a number of Plato's dialogues.
3. Critias, a first cousin of Plato's mother, was a figure in Athenian life and eventually became a member of the Thirty Tyrants who assumed power in Athens after its defeat to Sparta in the Peloponnesian War.
4. Charmides was an Athenian politician. He was Plato's uncle, and eventually became associated with the Thirty Tyrants, though it is unclear if he was actually a member of the Thirty. He is also mentioned in Plato's Symposium (222b), and Protagoras (315a).
5. A palaestra was a wrestling school.
6. Zalmoxis was a man who was worshipped as a deity by the Getae people in Thrace in northern Greece.
7. This is the grandfather of the Critias in this dialogue.
8. Pyrilampes was an Athenian statesman and stepfather of Plato. He served as ambassador to the Persian Empire.
9. Abaris the Hyperborean was a legendary sage and priest of Apollo who was endowed with the gift of prophecy.
10. Odyssey xvii.347.
11. Hesiod, Works and Days 311.
12. Following Schleiermacher.
13. Odyssey xix.562-567, where it is said of dreams that true ones come through the horn gate, while deceitful ones come through the ivory gate.

Clitophon

ΚΛΕΙΤΟΦΩΝ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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narrator: SOCRATES of Alopece, son of Sophroniscus

persons in the dialogue:

CLITOPHON *oligarchic political leader*

scene: no setting indicated

406a

Socrates: Someone told us recently that Clitophon¹, the son of Aristonymus, in conversation with Lysias², was critical of Socrates' discourses, while his praise of the instruction of Thrasymachus³ knew no bounds.

Clitophon: Whoever said so, Socrates, misinformed you about the discussion I had with Lysias concerning yourself. For although in some respects I did not praise you, in other respects I did. But since you are obviously rebuking me, while pretending to be unconcerned, I would be glad to recount these discussions to you myself now that we are on our own, so that you may be less inclined to believe that I think badly of you. Indeed, at the moment what you have heard is probably incorrect, and so you seem to be somewhat harder on me than I deserve. But if you allow me to speak freely, I'll do so gladly as I wish to explain myself.

407a

Socrates: Well, it would indeed be a shame for me to be intolerant when you are so eager to benefit me. For obviously, having recognised in what way I am good or bad, I shall practise and pursue the one and flee from the other as best I can.

407b

Clitophon: Listen then, for, while in your company, I was often amazed at what I was hearing, and I thought that in comparison with other speakers your discourse was the most exalted, as you rebuked the people like a god descending upon the tragic stage chanting your words: "People, whither are you being carried, ignorant of the fact that you are doing nothing you should do,

you who are so utterly serious about money and acquiring it for yourselves? Yet in the case of your sons to whom you will bequeath all this, you seek out no teachers of justice so that they will know how to use the wealth in a just manner, if this is actually teachable. But even if this is a matter of practice and exercise, you don't look for anyone who is up to the task of training them thoroughly and guiding them carefully, nor have you looked after yourselves in this way. Rather, when you see that yourselves and your children still prove to fare no better when it comes to using your wealth, despite being adequately instructed in writing, music and gymnastics, which you regard as a complete education in excel- that brother behaves towards brother and cities towards cities in an unmeasured and discordant manner, through conflict and warfare in which they carry out and suffer extremes of depravity. Yet you maintain that unjust people are unjust not because of a lack of education or because of ignorance, but intentionally, and again you dare to say further that injustice is shameful and detested by the gods. Now, how could anyone intentionally choose such an evil as this? Because, you reply, he is overcome by pleasures. But this is also unintentional, is it not, since to prevail is intentional? In any case, the argument proves that doing injustice is unintentional, and every man privately, and likewise all cities publicly, should exercise more care about this than they do at present." Now, Socrates, whenever I hear you saying all this, as you frequently do, I am much pleased, and I praise you wondrously; and also whenever you go on after this to say that those who develop their bodies but neglect souls are doing something else of this sort by being neglectful of the part that should rule, while attending to the part that should be ruled; and also when you say that it is better for someone to refrain from using whatever he knows not how to use. As, for instance, when someone knows not how to use eyes, ears or body as a whole, it is better for him neither to hear nor see nor use his

body for any other purpose rather than using it in any way whatsoever. And, indeed, the same holds for skill, since whoever does not know how to use his own lyre obviously does not know how to use his neighbour's lyre either, nor does anyone who does not know how to use other people's lyres know how to use his own lyre, nor any other instrument or possession at all. And this argument of yours then beautifully concludes that whoever knows not how to use soul is better off keeping his soul quiescent and not living at all, rather than being alive and acting according to his own whims. And if it is necessary for such a person to be alive, it is better that he spend his life as a slave rather than a free man, entrusting the rudder of his mind, just like a ship, to someone else who had learned the skill of steering humanity, which you, Socrates, often call statesmanship, saying that this is the same as jurisprudence and justice. Now, I have nothing to say against these arguments, and very many others of this sort, wonderfully expressed, stating that excellence is teachable and that we should care most of all for our own self. I do not really have anything to say against these, and I don't think I ever will, and I believe that they are exhortative in the extreme, and beneficial too, as if we are simply asleep and these are waking us up. So, I paid attention in order to hear what was to follow this, putting my questions, initially, not to yourself, Socrates, but to your like-minded comrades or companions, or whatever such associates of yours should be called. I first questioned those whom you held in the highest regard, asking them what argument would come next, and somewhat after your manner, I made a suggestion to them. "Best of men," said I, "how are we now to take Socrates' exhortation that we turn towards excellence? Is this all there is to say, and is it not possible to pursue the matter further and understand it completely? Is it to be our lifelong task to exhort those who have not yet been exhorted, and are they in turn to exhort others? Or should we ask Socrates, and one another, a

further question; having agreed that this is exactly what a human being is to do, what follows? How, according to us, should we start learning about justice? It's as if someone exhorted us to care for the body, having observed that we, like children, were unaware that there is such a thing as gymnastics and medicine. What if he were to reproach us on this basis, saying that it is a disgrace to care totally for wheat and barley and vines and whatever else we work for and acquire for the sake of the body, while searching neither for a skill nor a means whereby the body might be in as good a condition as possible, even though there are such skills? And what if we were to question the person who exhorted us in this way by asking him what these skills are? He would probably reply that these are gymnastics and medicine. In the present case then, what, according to us, is the skill concerned with the excellence of the soul? What do you say?" The one among them who was regarded as the most formidable in these matters replied to me. He told me what this skill was. "It is," said he, "the very one you hear Socrates speaking of, none other than justice." I replied by saying, "Don't just tell me its name. No, proceed as follows. Medicine is, presumably, a skill of which there are two outcomes, the first being ongoing production of additional physicians, the second being health. But the second of these is not yet a skill; it is rather the result of the skill of teaching and being taught, a result we call health. Similarly, in the case of the carpenter's skill, there is the house and there is carpentry, one being a result, the other being a subject that is taught. And the same applies to justice; one outcome is the production of just people in the same way that the other skills produce people with those particular skills. But what is its other outcome, the result that the just man can produce for us? What do we say this is? Tell me." That man replied, I believe, that it is 'the advantageous', another said that it is 'the appropriate', someone else suggested 'the beneficial', another 'the profitable'. So, I

returned to the question and said, “In the other realm too, these terms such as acting correctly, being profitable, beneficial, and so on, are applicable to any of the skills. But to what are these all directed? Each skill will give its own reply, and so carpentry, for instance, will say that what is good, beautiful, and necessary, is directed to the provision of wooden objects, which are, of course, not the skill itself. So, describe the result of justice in like manner.” Finally, Socrates, one of your companions replied with what seemed like the most ingenious response, saying that the particular result of justice, which belongs to none of the other skills, is to produce friendship in cities. This man, when questioned further, said that friendship is good and is never bad, and as the questioning continued, he would not accept that what we refer to as the friendship of children and beasts is indeed friendship. For he had to conclude that such friendships are, for the most part, harmful rather than good. So to avoid such a conclusion, he said that such friendships are not friendships at all, and that anyone who refers to them in this way is naming them falsely. And he said that real and true friendship is, precisely, like-mindedness. When asked whether he would say that the like-mindedness is likeness of opinion or of knowledge, he did not favour likeness of opinion because it is unavoidable that many instances of harmful likeness of opinion occur among people, while he had agreed that friendship is entirely good and is a result of justice. And so, he said like-mindedness was the same, being knowledge and not opinion. Now, at this stage in the argument we were getting nowhere. But those present were well able to take him to task and say that the argument had come full circle back to where we began and they said, “Medicine too is a sort of like-mindedness, and so are all of the skills and they are all able to say what they are concerned with. But what you call justice or like-mindedness has completely forgotten what it is directed towards, and there is no clarity as to what precisely the result of

justice is.” That’s why, Socrates, in the end, I also put the question to you, and you told me that justice is doing harm to enemies and good to friends. But later it turned out that a just person never harms anyone, since everything he does to anyone is for their benefit. Having been patient with this process, not once or twice but over a considerable time, my persistence failed me, and although I believe you are better than anyone at exhorting people to care for excellence, there are two possibilities; either this is as much as you can do and you can do no more, as if someone, without being a helmsman, were to teach himself to praise this skill as being of great value to humanity. And the same analogy applies to any of the skills, and so, in relation to justice, someone might accuse you of being none the more knowledgeable about justice simply because you are good at praising it. Now, I myself don’t think that this is the case, but there are two possibilities: either you are not knowledgeable or you are unwilling to share your knowledge with me. I think that’s why, in my perplexity, I go to Thrasymachus and to anyone else I can. But if you are prepared at this stage to stop giving me these exhortatory speeches, that’s what should happen now. Act as if I had been exhorted, in respect of gymnastics, not to neglect my body. Following your exhortatory speech, you would then explain the nature of my body and the sort of care it needs. Take it then that Clitophon agrees that it is laughable to care for other things while neglecting the soul for whose sake we work so hard at everything else. And at this stage you should also presume that I have, in this way, said whatever follows those arguments that I have gone through just now. So, I am saying, please just do as I ask so that I won’t do what I am now doing, praising you before Lysias, and before others in some respects, while criticising you in other respects. Indeed, Socrates, I declare that you are worth everything to a person who has not yet been exhorted, but to someone who has already been exhorted, you almost get in the

way of their attaining happiness by arriving at complete excellence.

NOTES

1. Clitophon was an Athenian statesman and thinker. He was involved in a coup that overthrew the democratic Athenian government and installed a short-lived oligarchy during the Peloponnesian War. He is an interlocutor of Socrates in Book I of the Republic 340a-d.
2. Lysias was an influential Athenian orator, Phaedrus 277a ff. He is present at the discussion in Book I of the Republic.
3. Thrasymachus was a sophist who is famously depicted conversing with Socrates in Book I of the Republic 336b ff.

Cratylus

ΚΡΑΤΥΛΟΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

HERMOGENES of Alopecce, son of Hipponicus

CRATYLUS of Athens, Heraclitean philosopher

scene: no dramatic setting

383a

Hermogenes: Well then, would you like to include Socrates here in our discussion?

Cratylus: If you wish.

Hermogenes: Socrates, Cratylus here maintains that there is a correctness of names that belongs, by nature, to each of the things that are, and what people conventionally call something when uttering some part of their own language is not this name. There is, rather, a natural correctness of names, the same for everyone, Greeks and non-Greeks alike. When I ask him if his own name is, in truth, Cratylus, he agrees that it is. “And what is Socrates’ name?” I ask. “Socrates,” says he. “Is this also the case with everyone else; whatever particular name we call them is their name in each case?” “Well,” says he, “your name is not Hermogenes, even if everyone calls you so.” And although I pursue the question and am keen to know what exactly he means, he clarifies nothing and hides his intention from me by pretending to be in possession of some personal understanding of his own about this matter, which, if he deigned to express it fully, would force me to agree with him and say exactly what he says. Now, if you can somehow interpret the oracular utterance of Cratylus, I would be pleased to hear you. But I would be even more pleased to find out from you, if you please, what you yourself think about the correctness of names.

384a

Socrates: Hermogenes, son of Hipponicus, there is an ancient saying that whatever is noble is difficult to understand, and

indeed the subject of names happens to be no small matter. Now, if I had already heard Prodicus' fifty-drachma course of lectures, which, according to the man himself, provides a comprehensive education in the subject, there would be nothing to stop you from learning the full truth about the correctness of names here and now. But as it happens, I have only heard his one-drachma course, so I don't really know where the truth about such matters lies. I am, however, prepared to join in the search together with yourself and Cratylus. But when he denies that Hermogenes is, in truth, your name, I suspect that he is mocking you, for he believes perhaps that every time you set out to make some money, you fail. In any case, as I said just now, although such matters are difficult to understand, we should make them the subject of a joint enquiry as to whether yourself or Cratylus is right.

384c

Hermogenes: Well, Socrates, for my part, although I have often been involved in discussions with this man and with many others, I cannot be persuaded that there is any correctness of a name apart from convention and agreement. Indeed, it seems to me that whatever name you give to something is the correct name, and if you change the name for a different one and no longer use the original name, the new name is just as correct as the previous one. It is just like changing the names of your household slaves, for no name naturally belongs to any particular thing by nature, but by convention and custom on the part of those who create the custom and use the name. If this is not the case, I myself am quite prepared to listen and learn, not only from Cratylus, but from anyone else at all.

385a

Socrates: Perhaps you have a point, Hermogenes, but let's see. According to you, whatever someone calls something is the name of that thing.

Hermogenes: That's what I think anyway.

Socrates: Whether an individual or, indeed, a city calls it so?

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: What about this? Suppose I call any of the things that are, for instance, what we currently call a man, suppose I refer to this as a horse, and what we now call a horse as a man, will the same thing have the name 'man' for the general public, and 'horse' for me personally? And in the other case, will the same thing have the name 'man' for me, and 'horse' for the public? Is that what you are saying?

385b

Hermogenes: That's what I think, anyway.

Socrates: Come on then and tell me this. Is there something you call speaking the truth and something you call speaking falsehood?

Hermogenes: There is.

Socrates: So there can be a true statement and a false statement?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: Is the statement that states things that are as they are, true, while the one that states them as they are not, is false?

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: So, is it possible in a statement to state things that are and things that are not?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

385c

Socrates: But is a true statement true as a whole, while parts of it are not true?

Hermogenes: No, the parts are also true.

Socrates: But are the large parts true while the small parts are not, or are they all true?

Hermogenes: I think they are all true.

Socrates: Now, is there any part of a spoken statement that is smaller than a name?

Hermogenes: No, that is the smallest.

Socrates: And is this name spoken as part of a true statement?

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: And according to you at least, this part is true.

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: While part of a false statement is false, is it not?

Hermogenes: I agree.

Socrates: So, since it is possible to utter a true and false statement, is it also possible to utter a true and a false name?

385d

Hermogenes: Of course.

Socrates: So, whatever a person says is the name of something, this name is its name for that person?

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: And however many names someone says that a particular thing has, it will indeed have that many names then, whenever he says so?

Hermogenes: Yes, Socrates, I can conceive no other correctness of names apart from this: I call something by one name, the name I gave it, and you call it something else, the name you, for your part, gave it. And, in the same way, I notice that various cities have different set names of their own for the same things; Greeks differ from other Greeks, as do Greeks from non-Greeks.

385e

Socrates: Come on now, Hermogenes, let's see whether, in your view, this is also the case with things that are. Is it the case that their being is private to each person, and so, as Protagoras said, the measure of all things is man, and consequently, as things appear to me, so they are for me, and as they appear to you, so they are for you? Or do you think that things have some fixity of being of their own?

386a

Hermogenes: On occasion, Socrates, out of sheer perplexity, I have ended up saying just what Protagoras says, even though I don't entirely believe that this is the case.

386b

Socrates: What about this, then? Have you ever ended up not entirely believing that there is such a thing as a bad person?

Hermogenes: No, by Zeus, I have often come to the conclusion that some people are entirely bad, a very large number actually.

Socrates: Well, have you ever thought that some are very good?

Hermogenes: Very few indeed.

Socrates: But you do think so?

Hermogenes: I do.

Socrates: And where do you stand on the following question? Are those who are very good also very wise, while the very bad are very foolish?

386c

Hermogenes: Yes, I think that this is so.

Socrates: Now, if Protagoras spoke the truth and it is actually true that, for each person, as things seem so things are, is it possible that some people are wise while others are foolish?

Hermogenes: No, it is not.

Socrates: Then I believe you are strongly of the view that since there is wisdom and there is folly, Protagoras cannot possibly be speaking the truth. For presumably no one could be wiser than anyone else, if whatever seems true for each person is true for that person.

386d

Hermogenes: Indeed so.

Socrates: Nor indeed, I believe, do you hold to the opinion of Euthydemus, that everything is always simultaneously so for everyone in like manner, since if excellence and vice always belong to everyone in like manner, some people could not be good while others were bad.

Hermogenes: That's true.

Socrates: Therefore, if everything is not always simultaneously so for everyone in like manner, nor does each thing belong to each individual person, it is obvious that things are possessed of some definite being of their own, not relative to us, nor dragged hither and thither by how they appear to us. Rather, they hold, of themselves, to their own being which is natural to them.

386e

Hermogenes: Yes, Socrates, I believe that this is so.

Socrates: Now, could things be so by nature, while the same is not so for the actions belonging to the things? Or do the actions themselves also constitute a species among things that are?

Hermogenes: They do, indeed.

387a

Socrates: So, the actions are enacted according to their own nature and not in accordance with our opinion. For instance, what if we try to cut anything at all, may we cut this as we please, with whatever we please, or if we wish to cut this in accordance with the nature of cutting and being cut, and with what is natural, will we make the cut and succeed in doing so

correctly, but go awry and achieve nothing if we act contrary to nature?

387b

Hermogenes: Yes, I think this is the case.

Socrates: And if we attempt to burn something, we should not burn it in accordance with every opinion, but in accordance with the correct one which corresponds to the way in which this is naturally burned or burns, and with what is natural.

Hermogenes: Quite so.

Socrates: Does the same hold for other activities?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: Now, speaking is one of these activities, is it not?

Hermogenes: Yes.

387c

Socrates: What if someone speaks as he thinks he should speak? Will he be speaking correctly when he speaks in this way, or will he be successful in speaking only if he speaks of matters in a way that is natural for him to speak of them and for them to be spoken of? Otherwise, won't he go awry and achieve nothing?

Hermogenes: I think that's how matters stand.

Socrates: Now, naming is part of speaking, for we speak what we speak, I presume, by making distinctions based upon names.

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: And naming is indeed an activity, since speaking is also an activity in relation to things, is it not?

Hermogenes: Yes.

387d

Socrates: And activities, we saw, are not relative to us, but have a particular nature of their own?

Hermogenes: Quite so.

Socrates: Then, if we are not to contradict our previous conclusions, should things be named in the way that is natural to name them, and for them to be named with what is natural and not as we wish? And shall we meet with success in naming things in this way and no other?

Hermogenes: Apparently so.

Socrates: Come on then, are we saying that something that has to be cut, has to be cut with something?

Hermogenes: Yes.

387e

Socrates: And does something that has to be woven have to be woven with something, and does whatever has to be bored have to be bored with something?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: And does whatever has to be named have to be named with something?

388a

Hermogenes: It does.

Socrates: With what should something be bored?

Hermogenes: A drill.

Socrates: With what should something be woven?

Hermogenes: A shuttle.

Socrates: And with what should something be named?

Hermogenes: A name.

Socrates: Well said. So the name is also an instrument.

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: Now, suppose I were to ask what instrument is the shuttle. Isn't it the one with which we weave?

Hermogenes: Yes.

388b

Socrates: And when we are weaving what do we do? Don't we separate the commingled warp and woof threads?

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: Wouldn't you answer in the same way about a drill and about the other instruments?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: Can you answer then in the same way about a name? When naming with the name, which is an instrument, what are we doing?

Hermogenes: I cannot answer.

Socrates: Are we not instructing one another about something, and separating things as they are?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

388c

Socrates: So a name is an instrument of instruction and it divides being, just as a shuttle does for woven fabric.

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: So a shuttle is for weaving?

Hermogenes: Of course.

Socrates: So a weaver will use a shuttle well, and well means after the manner of a weaver, while an instructor will use a name well, and well means after the manner of an instructor.

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: When a weaver uses a shuttle well, whose work does he use?

Hermogenes: The work of the carpenter.

Socrates: And is everyone a carpenter, or the person who has that skill?

Hermogenes: The person with the skill.

388d

Socrates: When a borer uses a drill well, whose work does he use?

Hermogenes: The work of the blacksmith.

Socrates: And is everyone a blacksmith, or the person who has the skill?

Hermogenes: The person with the skill.

Socrates: Very well. And when an instructor uses a name, whose work does he use?

Hermogenes: I can't say.

Socrates: Well, can you answer this question? Who has given us the names that we make use of?

Hermogenes: I cannot.

Socrates: Don't you think that convention has given these to us?

Hermogenes: So it seems.

388e

Socrates: So when an instructor makes use of a name, is he using the work of the conventionsetter?

Hermogenes: I think so.

Socrates: And do you think everyone is a convention-setter, or the person who has the skill?

Hermogenes: The person with the skill.

389a

Socrates: So, Hermogenes, it is not for everyone to give names, but for some fashioner of names who is, it seems, the convention-setter, the rarest of artificers to arise among us humans.

Hermogenes: So it seems.

Socrates: Come on then, let's investigate where the convention-setter looks when giving names. Let us consider this based upon the previous examples. Where does the carpenter look when making a shuttle? Does he not look to the sort of thing whose nature is to weave?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

389b

Socrates: What about this? If the shuttle breaks while he is making it, will he make another one by looking to the broken one, or to that form towards which he was looking when he made the one that broke?

Hermogenes: Yes, I think he would look to that form.

Socrates: Isn't that what we would rightly call "what a shuttle is"?

Hermogenes: I think so.

Socrates: And whether he needs to make a shuttle for a light or heavy garment, for linen or for wool or for any sort at all, it should indeed possess the form of the shuttle, but in each case mustn't he give it the nature that is naturally best for its particular function?

389c

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: And the same holds for the other instruments. On discovering the natural instrument for each particular task, he should impose that upon whatever it is to be made from, not as he pleases but as is natural. So he must, it seems, know how to impose upon the iron the drill that is natural for each particular task.

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: And impose upon the wood the natural shuttle for each particular task.

Hermogenes: Indeed.

389d

Socrates: Then each shuttle, it seems, is for a particular kind of weaving, and the same applies to the other instruments.

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: So, best of men, does the convention-setter need to know how to impose that natural name for each thing upon the sounds and syllables, and make and impose all names by looking to what name itself is if he is to be an authoritative giver of names? And if a particular convention-setter does not impose the name upon the same syllables, this name should not be doubted. For neither does every smith, making the same instrument for the same task, impose it upon the same iron, but, nevertheless, as long as he bestows the same form, even on the different iron, the instrument retains its correctness, whether it is made here or in non-Greek cities. Is this so?

390a

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: Won't you evaluate the convention-setter, either here or among non-Greek peoples, in this way too? As long as he imposes the appropriate form of the name upon each thing, in syllables of any sort, isn't he just as good a convention-setter,

here or anywhere else?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

390b

Socrates: Now, who is the one who knows whether the appropriate form of shuttle is embodied in wood of any kind? Is it the carpenter who has made it, or the weaver who uses it?

Hermogenes: The user, Socrates, is more likely to know this.

Socrates: Now, who is the person who uses the product of the lyre maker? Isn't he the one who knows how best to supervise its manufacture, and would recognise whether or not it had been well made, once it had been made?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: And who is this person?

Hermogenes: The lyre player.

Socrates: And what about the work of a shipbuilder?

390c

Hermogenes: A ship's captain is best.

Socrates: And who would best supervise the work of the convention-setter, and pass judgement when it is complete, in this country or abroad? Won't it be the person who uses his work?

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: Is this not the person who knows how to ask questions?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: Does the same person know how to respond?

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: Do you call the person who knows how to ask questions and respond a dialectician?

Hermogenes: Yes, a dialectician.

390d

Socrates: So the work of the carpenter is to make a rudder under the supervision of the ship's captain, if the rudder is to be a good one.

Hermogenes: Apparently.

Socrates: And the work of the convention-setter, it seems, is to make a name, with the dialectical person as supervisor, if names are to be properly given.

Hermogenes: Indeed so.

Socrates: It seems then, Hermogenes, that the giving of a name is not, as you imagine, an ordinary matter for ordinary random persons. And Cratylus is speaking the truth when he says that the names belong to the things by their nature, and not everyone is an artificer of names, but only the person who looks to the natural name for each and is able to impose its form upon the letters and syllables.

391a

Hermogenes: I don't know how to oppose your arguments, Socrates, and yet it is not easy for me to be persuaded so suddenly, and I think I would be better persuaded if you were to show me what, according to you, this natural correctness of names is.

Socrates: Bless you, Hermogenes, I am not saying that there is any such thing. No, you have forgotten what I said a little earlier, that I don't know about this, but I could enquire along with you. And as we now investigate this, you and I, this much progress is already apparent; a name does have some natural correctness and it is not every man who knows how to give this

to anything at all. Isn't this so?

391b

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: Therefore, if you have a desire to know, the next thing we should do is to investigate what precisely the correctness of name is.

Hermogenes: But of course I want to know.

Socrates: Then enquire.

Hermogenes: How should I enquire?

Socrates: The correct way to enquire, my friend, is in the company of those who know, but you pay money to them and you owe them a debt of gratitude. These people are the sophists from whom your brother Callias has acquired his reputation for wisdom, having paid them a great deal of money. But since you are not in control of your own inheritance, you must implore your brother and ask him to teach you what he learned from Protagoras about the correctness applicable to such matters as these.

391c

Hermogenes: Socrates, coming from me such a request would be strange indeed – that I, who do not accept Protagoras' truth at all, should place any value upon the details of such a truth as this.

391d

Socrates: Well, if that does not please you, then you should learn from Homer and the other poets.

Hermogenes: And what does Homer say about names, Socrates, and where?

Socrates: There are many places where he makes significant, fine distinctions between the names that humans and the gods call the same things. Don't you agree that there are places

where he says something wonderfully important about the correctness of names? For it is surely obvious that the gods call things by names that are correct by nature. Don't you think so?

391e

Hermogenes: I fully understand that if the gods call things by names, they do so correctly. But what passages are you referring to?

Socrates: Don't you know that he says that the Trojan river that fought one on one with Hephaestus is called Xanthos by the gods, but Scamander by humans?

Hermogenes: I do.

392a

Socrates: What about this? Don't you think this is something special, to know that this river is more correctly called Xanthos rather than Scamander? Or take, if you like, the example of the bird which he says: the gods have called Chalcis but humans call Cymnidis. Do you think it is an ordinary matter to learn how much more correct it is to call the same bird Chalcis rather than Cymindis? Or what about the hill that is called both Batieia and Myrina, and many other examples from this poet and various others? But perhaps these matters are too exalted for you and I to understand, whereas Scamandrius and Astyanax are more amenable to human investigation, as, in my opinion, it is easier to investigate what he maintains are the names of Hector's son and what precisely he means by the correctness of these. I am sure that you know the lines that include these references.

392b

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: Well, which name do you think Homer believed to be the more correct name for the boy – Astyanax or Scamandrius?

392c

Hermogenes: I cannot say.

Socrates: Think about this, then. Suppose someone were to ask you, “Do you think that the more intelligent person or the more unintelligent person calls things by the more correct names?”

Hermogenes: I would say that it is obviously the more intelligent person.

Socrates: Now in your opinion, on the whole, are the women in a city, or the men, the more intelligent group?

Hermogenes: The men.

Socrates: Now, you know, don’t you, that Homer says that Hector’s child was called Astyanax by the men of Troy. And since the men called him Astyanax, he was obviously called Scamandrius by the women?

392d

Hermogenes: Well, so it seems.

Socrates: Didn’t Homer too believe that the Trojan men were wiser than their women?

Hermogenes: I think so.

Socrates: So, he thought that Astyanax was a more correct name for the boy than Scamandrius.

Hermogenes: Apparently.

Socrates: Then, let’s look at the precise reason for this. Or does he himself explain the reason very nicely? Indeed, he says: ^{392e} he alone defended their city and long walls For this reason, then, it seems it is only right to call the son of the defender, Astyanax, the astu-anax, the lord of the city, which his father defended, as Homer says.

392e

Hermogenes: I see.

Socrates: But why, exactly? Indeed, I myself do not yet understand. Do you understand, Hermogenes?

Hermogenes: By Zeus, I do not.

393a

Socrates: But, good man, did Homer himself not give Hector this name?

Hermogenes: What of it?

Socrates: Well, this name seems to me to be much the same as Astyanax. Indeed, both seem to be Greek, for anax (lord) and hector (possessor) seem to indicate the same thing since both are names for a king, for surely a person is also the possessor of whatever he is lord of since he is obviously in control of this, and has acquired it and possesses it. Or do you think I am talking nonsense in the deluded belief that I have found some clue to Homer's opinion about the correctness of names?

393b

Hermogenes: By Zeus, you are not deluded. No, you have probably found something.

Socrates: At any rate, it is right, as I see it, to call the offspring of a lion, a lion, and the offspring of a horse, a horse. I am not speaking of a case where something other than a horse is born from a horse, a sort of aberration. I am referring, rather, to the natural offspring of its kind. If a horse, contrary to nature, were to give birth to a calf, the natural offspring of a cow, it should not be called a foal but a calf. Nor, in my opinion, if non-human offspring is born from a human being, should that offspring be called a human being. And the same applies to trees and to everything else. Don't you agree?

393c

Hermogenes: I do.

Socrates: Good, but be on your guard lest I somehow lead you astray, since, according to the same argument, any offspring born from a king should be called a king. But whether the same thing is indicated by one set of syllables or by another set does

not matter. Nor does it matter if a letter is added or subtracted as long as the essence of the thing is in control and is revealed in the name.

393d

Hermogenes: How do you mean?

Socrates: Nothing complicated. No, this is something you already know. We speak the names of the letters but not the letters themselves, with four exceptions: e, u, o and ō. And you know that we attach additional spoken letters to the other vowels and consonants in order to make names for them. But as long as we include the demonstrative power of the letter, we are right to call it by that name, and for us, that will indicate it. Take beta for example. You see that adding 'b' and 't' and 'a' does no harm and does not prevent the nature of the consonant from being indicated by the whole name of the letter that the convention-setter wished to name, and so he knew quite well how to give names to the letters.

393e

Hermogenes: Yes, I think that's true.

394a

Socrates: Doesn't the same argument hold in relation to a king? For a king will usually be born from a king, good from good, noble from noble, and the same holds for all other cases; from each kind, another one like that is born unless some aberration arises. So they should be called by the same names, but it is permissible to vary the syllables so that to those without the expertise, names seem different even though they are the same, just like drugs prepared by physicians, which vary in colour and smell and appear different although they are the same. And yet, to the physician who discerns the power of the drugs, they appear the same and he is not misled by the additions. And so, in like manner, someone who is knowledgeable about names sees the power they possess and is not misled if a letter is added,

transposed or removed, or indeed if the power of the name is conveyed by completely different letters. For instance, in the case we have just described, 'Astyanax' and 'Hector' have no letters the same except 't', but they indicate the same thing. And what letters does 'Archepolis' (ruler of the city) have in common with these? Yet it signifies the same thing nevertheless, and there are many other names which simply indicate 'king'.

394c

Socrates: And again, there are others that indicate 'general', such as 'Agis' (leader), 'Polemarchus' (battle leader) and 'Eupolemus' (good in battle), and indeed such names as 'Iatrocles' (famous healer) and 'Acesimbrotus' (healer of mortals) indicate 'physician'. And we might find lots of others differing in their syllables and letters but having the same power when uttered. Is this so?

394d

Hermogenes: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: In that case, those that come into being in accordance with nature should be assigned the same names.

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: What about those that have come into being, contrary to nature, in the form of some aberration? For instance, when a disrespectful child is born to a good man who respects the gods – as in our previous example of a horse giving birth to a calf – it should not, of course, bear the name of the parent, but of the sort of thing that it is.

Hermogenes: Certainly.

394e

Socrates: Then a disrespectful child born to a respectful person should be given the name of the disrespectful kind.

Hermogenes: Indeed so.

Socrates: So he should not, it seems, be called ‘Theophilus’ (beloved of God) or ‘Mnēsitheos’ (mindful of God) or anything of that sort, but by a name that indicates the opposite of these, if names are to be correct.

Hermogenes: Very much so, Socrates.

Socrates: Yes, Hermogenes, just as the name ‘Orestēs’ (mountain-man) is likely to be correct, whether it was given to him by chance or by a poet to point out with this name the wildness, coarseness and ruggedness of his nature.

395a

Hermogenes: Apparently so, Socrates.

Socrates: And it seems that his father’s name is also in accord with nature.

Hermogenes: Apparently.

Socrates: Indeed, it is quite likely that Agamemnon is the sort of person who would work hard at whatever he decided upon, and persevere, bringing his plans to completion through his excellence, and an indication of this is the length of his stay at Troy and his endurance. So, the name ‘Agamemnon’ indicates that this man was admirable (agastos) for standing his ground (epimonē). And the name ‘Atreus’ is probably correct too, for his murder of Chrysippus and his cruel treatment of Thyestēs were all destructive and ruinous (atēra) to his excellence. Now, the significance of the name is slightly altered and obscured so that the nature of the man is not obvious to everyone. But to those with an understanding of names, it adequately demonstrates what Atreus means. Indeed, whether in respect of his stubbornness (ateires), his fearlessness (atrestos), or his ruinousness (atēros), the name is correctly applied in any case. And I think that Pelops also has an appropriate name, for this name indicates someone who sees what is close at hand.

395c

Hermogenes: How do you mean?

Socrates: We are told, for instance, that in murdering Myrtilus he proved unable to anticipate or foresee the far-reaching consequences for his entire family, and the extent of the misfortune that would befall them. In his eagerness to secure his marriage to Hippodameia by any means, he saw only what was close at hand and immediate or near (pelas). And if what we are told about Tantalus is true, then everyone would agree that his name too has been correctly given, in accordance with his nature.

395d

Hermogenes: What are you referring to?

Socrates: To the many terrible misfortunes that happened to him during his life, culminating in the overthrow of his own fatherland, and, after death in Hades, in amazing concord with his name, a stone was suspended (talanteia) over his head. And it really seems as if someone, wishing to call him ‘Talantatos’ (weighed down completely), has disguised this intention and named him by saying ‘Tantalus’ instead. The circumstances of the legend seem to have provided this name for him in some such manner as this. And it appears that his father, who is said to be Zeus, also had an excellent name, although it is not easy to understand. For the name of Zeus is really like a phrase consisting of two parts, some people using one part, others using the other. For some call him Zēn, others Dia, and combining the two into one demonstrates the nature of the god, which, according to us, is what a name should be able to do. For there is no one who is more responsible for the life of us humans, and all other creatures, than the ruler and king of all. Consequently, this god through whom (di hon) all living creatures always have life (zēn) has been named correctly (di hon zēn). And as I said, the name, being one, is divided into two parts, Dia and Zēn. To suggest that he is the son of Cronus might

seem disrespectful on first hearing, and to say that Zeus is the offspring of some huge intellect might sound preferable. For *koros* (representing Cronus) does not indicate a child, but the pure (*kathoros*) and unblemished nature of reason (*nous*).

396b

Socrates: And he, the story goes, is the son of Uranus, and the upward vision is rightly called ‘*ourania*’, looking upwards (*horōsa* – looking, *ta anō* – above), and those who study the heavens, Hermogenes, say that this results in pure reason and Uranus has the correct name. And if I could have remembered the genealogy of Hesiod, where he describes even earlier ancestors of these gods, I could have continued explaining that they too had correct names, until I had tested this wisdom that has suddenly come upon me like this, I know not from where, to see whether or not it will ebb away.

396d

Hermogenes: Yes, indeed, Socrates, you really do seem to me, suddenly, to be making prophetic utterances, just like inspired people.

Socrates: Well, Hermogenes, for the most part I blame what has happened to me on Euthyphro of Prospaltia. Indeed, I was with him for a long time this morning and I was listening to him, and it is quite likely that he was so inspired that he not only filled my ears with his godly wisdom but has taken possession of my soul too. So, I think this is what we need to do. For today, let’s make use of this wisdom and continue our investigation into the remaining names, and tomorrow, if you agree, we shall send it on its way and be purified, having found someone, either a priest or a sophist, who is adept in such purifications.

397a

Hermogenes: Yes, I agree. And I would be very glad to listen to whatever remains to be said about names.

Socrates: Well, that is what we should do then. Now, since we have hit upon this general approach, where would you like us to begin our investigation so that we may see whether the names themselves shall act as witnesses and tell us whether each name is merely given at random, or actually possesses a certain correctness? Now, the names in use for heroes and humans may perhaps be deceiving us, for many of them are based on the names of ancestors, and in some cases, as we said at the outset, they are quite inappropriate, while many such as Eutychides (fortunate), Sosias (saviour) and Theophilus (beloved of God) are given in a spirit of prayer. Now, in my opinion, we should leave names of that sort aside as we are most likely to find those that are correctly given when dealing with whatever is eternal and natural. For in such cases, it was most appropriate that the assignment of names be taken seriously. And perhaps some of them were given by a power more divine than any human power.

397c

Hermogenes: I think that's well expressed, Socrates.

Socrates: Now, wouldn't it be right to begin with the gods and consider the way in which the 'gods' (theoi) are correctly called by this particular name?

Hermogenes: Quite likely.

Socrates: Well, my guess is as follows. As I see it, the first humans to settle in Greece believed only in those gods that many non-Greeks still believe in today – sun, moon, stars and sky. Now, since they saw that these are always following a course, and running (theonta), they named them 'gods' (theous) because their nature is to run (thein). Later, recognising the other gods, they called them all by this same name. Is this likely to be true or am I talking nonsense?

397d

Hermogenes: It is very likely.

Socrates: What should we look at after this?

^{397e}

Hermogenes: Daimōnes (divine beings), of course.

Socrates: And what exactly does the name ‘daimōnes’ mean in truth, Hermogenes? You may decide whether there is anything in what I am about to say.

Hermogenes: Speak on.

Socrates: Do you know what daimōnes are, according to Hesiod?

Hermogenes: I cannot recall.

Socrates: Don’t you recall that he says that the first race of humans to be born was a golden race?

Hermogenes: Yes, I know that much anyway.

Socrates: Well, what he says about it is: But since this race has been concealed by fate, ^{398a} they are called sacred daimōnes who dwell beneath the earth, ^{398a} noble, averters of evil, guardians of mortal men.

^{398a}

Hermogenes: Yes, what of it?

Socrates: Well, I think he means not that this race is golden by nature, but that it is good and noble for me, the fact that he refers to ourselves as an iron race is proof of this.

Hermogenes: That’s true.

Socrates: And if anyone nowadays happened to be good, don’t you think he would say that he belonged to that golden race?

^{398b}

Hermogenes: Quite likely.

Socrates: And are the good also wise?

Hermogenes: Yes, wise.

Socrates: Well this, I believe, is what he really means. Because the daimōnes were wise and knowledgeable (daimonēs), he called them daimōnes, and in our ancient language this very name is found. So, Hesiod and many other poets are right when they say that once a good person dies, a great and honourable destiny is theirs, and the person becomes a daimōn in accordance with the wisdom associated with that title. And, accordingly, I too maintain that anyone who is good is daimōnic, whether they be living or deceased, and is correctly called a daimōn.

398c

Hermogenes: Yes, Socrates, I think I am in complete agreement with you on this. But what about the word ‘hero’? What would it be?

Socrates: This is not particularly difficult to understand, for their name is little altered and it indicates their birth from love (erōs).

Hermogenes: How do you mean?

Socrates: Don’t you know that heroes are demigods?

Hermogenes: What of it?

398d

Socrates: They have all been born from the love (erōs) of a god or a goddess for a mortal. And if you look at this based upon the old Attic tongue, you will understand better. For it will show you that ‘hero’ is a slight alteration of the name of ‘love’ (erōs) from which heroes are born. So they are called heroes either for this reason or because they are sophists, clever speakers, dialecticians who are well able to ask questions (erōtan). For ‘erein’ is the same as ‘legein’ (to speak). And so, as we have just said, heroes, when spoken of in the Attic tongue, turn out to be rhetoricians and questioners, and our tribe of heroes becomes a

race of rhetoricians and sophists. Now, this is not difficult to understand, but it is harder to understand why exactly members of the human race are called humans. Can you say?

398e

Hermogenes: How could I, my friend? Even if I were able to find out, I wouldn't make the effort because I believe you are more likely to make the discovery than I am.

399a

Socrates: It seems that you believe in the inspiration of Euthyphro.

Hermogenes: Of course.

Socrates: Well, you are right to believe in it. Indeed, I myself apparently have come up with such an ingenious notion just now that if I am not careful I am in danger this very day of becoming wiser than I need to be. Consider this. In the first place it is necessary to recognise that when it comes to names, we often insert letters or remove them, departing from our intention in naming, and we sometimes change the accents. For example, in order to turn the phrase 'dii philos' (friend of Zeus) into a name, we removed the second 'i' and pronounced the middle syllable with a grave rather than an acute accent (diphilus). In other cases, by contrast, we insert letters and pronounce grave accents as acute.

399b

Hermogenes: True.

Socrates: Well, it seems to me that the name for human beings has also undergone such a process. One letter, 'a', has been removed and the final syllable has become grave, turning a phrase into a name.

Hermogenes: How do you mean?

399c

Socrates: As follows. This name, ‘human’ (anthrōpos), indicates that the other creatures do not consider or reflect upon or scrutinise anything they see, while a human being sees (opōpe) and simultaneously scrutinises and reflects upon whatever has been seen. And so, of all creatures, a human being is rightly named ‘human’ (anthrōpos) for scrutinising (anathrōn) whatever is seen (opōpe).

Hermogenes: Well, what next? May I ask about the next thing I would like to find out?

Socrates: Certainly.

399d

Hermogenes: After these examples, there is, I think, something that follows naturally. Indeed, we speak, I presume, of the body and the soul of a human being.

Socrates: Of course.

Hermogenes: Then let’s analyse these names too, just as we did with the previous ones.

Socrates: Do you mean that we should consider how soul reasonably comes by that name, and do the same too for body?

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: Well, speaking off-hand, I think that those who gave soul its name had something as follows in mind. They observed that when soul is present it is the cause of the body being alive, providing its ability to draw breath and be revived, and when the reviving (anapsuchon) power departs, the body is destroyed and dies. And that, I believe, is why they called it ‘soul’ (psychē). But, quiet please. I think I can discern something more persuasive to Euthyphro and his followers who, in my opinion, would despise this interpretation and regard it as commonplace. Let’s see if you like this.

400a

Hermogenes: Speak on.

Socrates: Do you think that there is anything besides soul that sustains the nature of every single body, so that it lives and moves?

Hermogenes: There is nothing else.

Socrates: What about this? Don't you also believe, with Anaxagoras, that nous and soul are what order and hold the nature of everything else too?

Hermogenes: I do.

400b

Socrates: So, it would be only right to give to this power, which holds and sustains (orchei, echei) nature (phusis), this particular name, 'phusechei' (nature-holder). And it is possible to pronounce this more elegantly as 'psuchē' (soul).

Hermogenes: Entirely so, and I think this explanation is more skilful than the first one.

Socrates: Indeed so, although to give it its true name (phusechei) certainly sounds odd.

Hermogenes: Yes, but what should we say about the next word?

Socrates: Do you mean 'body'?

Hermogenes: Yes.

400c

Socrates: There is, I think, much to say, and if the word is altered slightly there is even more to say. And indeed, some maintain that the body (sōma) is a tomb (sēma) for the soul, as though it was, at present, entombed. Or again, because body indicates (sēmainei) whatever the soul would indicate (sēmainēi), it is accordingly correctly called an 'indication' (sēma). But it seems to me for the most part that this name was

given by the adherents of Orpheus as if the soul was paying a penalty for some offences, and the body was an enclosure like a prison to keep the soul safe. So the body (sōma) is a safe (sōma) for the soul until such time as it has paid for its offences in full, and body is named accordingly and there is no need to alter a single letter.

400d

Hermogenes: Well, Socrates, I think that enough has been said on these names. But what about the names of the gods – Zeus for instance, whom you spoke of just now? Should we conduct an enquiry in the same way as to where precisely the correctness of their names lies?

Socrates: Yes, by Zeus, Hermogenes, if we are possessed of any intelligence, the very best approach is to admit that we know nothing about the gods themselves, nor about the precise names they call themselves, which are of course true names. But, in terms of correctness, a second approach would be to call them by the names they love to be called by in our conventional prayers, since we know nothing else. In fact, this custom seems good to me, so if you like, let's conduct our investigation by first announcing to the gods that, because we are unworthy to do so, we shall not be investigating them, but human beings and the opinions they held when they gave the gods those names. For this approach will avoid divine retribution.

401a

Hermogenes: Yes, Socrates, that sounds reasonable to me. Let's do as you suggest.

401b

Socrates: Should we begin in the customary manner with Hestia?

Hermogenes: Right.

Socrates: Well, what would you say was in the mind of whoever gave Hestia her name?

Hermogenes: By Zeus, I don't think that's an easy question to answer either.

Socrates: It is quite likely, Hermogenes, that the first name givers were not ordinary folk but lofty thinkers with much to say.

Hermogenes: What of it?

401c

Socrates: It is obvious to me that people of this sort gave the names, and if names in foreign languages are investigated, the meaning of each will be discovered just as well. For instance, in the case of what we call 'ousia' (being), there are some who call this 'essia' and others who call it 'ōsia'. Now, taking the first of these alternatives, essia, it is reasonable to call the being of things 'Hestia', and furthermore, we also say that whatever partakes of being 'is' (estin), and on this basis could be correctly named Hestia. For we seem, in ancient times, to have called 'ousia' (being), 'essia'. But someone, thinking of sacrifices, might also conclude that the name-givers had this in mind, for those who call the being of everything 'essia' are likely to sacrifice to Hestia first before any other gods. Those, on the other hand, who called being 'ōsia' would agree, more or less, with Heraclitus that all of the things that are are in motion, and nothing remains as it is. So, their cause and ruler is that which pushes (ōthoun), and it was right therefore to name it 'ōsia'. And that is as much as we who know nothing should say. After Hestia, it is only right to investigate 'Rhea' and 'Cronus'. The name of Cronus we have already dealt with. But perhaps I talk nonsense.

401e

Hermogenes: Why so, Socrates?

Socrates: A swarm of wisdom has come into my mind, my friend.

Hermogenes: What sort of a swarm?

402a

Socrates: Well, it is most odd to recount, but I think it does carry a certain conviction.

Hermogenes: Which is?

Socrates: I seem to picture Heraclitus uttering ancient words of wisdom from the era of Cronus and Rhea, spoken also by Homer.

Hermogenes: What do you mean?

Socrates: Heraclitus says, I presume, that everything is in motion and nothing remains as it is, and he compares things that are to the flow of a river, saying that “you cannot step twice into the same river”.

Hermogenes: So he does.

402b

Socrates: Now, do you think that whoever gave the names Rhea and Cronus to the ancestors of the other gods thought differently from Heraclitus? Do you think he gave the names of streams to both of them just by chance? Just as Homer for his part refers to “Ocean the origin of the gods, and mother Tethys”, as I believe does Hesiod. Orpheus too says, I believe, that: 402c First to wed was fair flowing Ocean. 402c Who took to wife his sister, Tethys, his mother’s child. Notice that they are in agreement with one another, and they all incline towards the doctrines of Heraclitus.

402c

Hermogenes: What you are saying makes sense to me, Socrates. But I do not understand what the name ‘Tethys’ means.

Socrates: But the name itself is almost stating that it is a disguised name for a spring. For that which sifts (diattomenon)

and filters (ēthoumenon) represents a spring and the name Tethys combines both of these words.

402d

Hermogenes: That is elegant, Socrates.

Socrates: It certainly is. But what is next? Zeus, we have already explained.

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: Then let's speak about his brothers, Poseidon and Pluto, and the other name he goes by.

Hermogenes: Certainly.

402e

Socrates: Well, it seems to me that Poseidon is so named because the nature of the sea hindered him as he proceeded and would not allow him to advance, acting as a sort of bond for his feet. So, the god with dominion over the power of the sea was named Poseidon because he was foot-bound (posi-desmon) and the 'e' was probably added to improve the sound. But perhaps it does not mean this, and it was spoken initially with a double 'l' in place of the 's' because the god knows (eidota) a great deal (polla). Or perhaps he was named 'the Shaker' (ho seiōn) because of his shaking activity, and the 'p' and the 'd' are additions. Pluto is named as the giver of wealth (ploutos) because wealth comes up from beneath the earth. It seems to me that most people assume that his name refers to the unseen (aides), so out of fear they call him Pluto.

403b

Hermogenes: And what is your view of the matter, Socrates?

Socrates: Well, it seems to me that people have been misled in many ways about the power of this god and are unjustifiably afraid of him. They are afraid because once any of us dies we remain forever in his realm, and because our soul arrives before him bereft of a body, they are also fearful on that account. But

in my opinion, all of this, and the dominion and name of the god, point to the same conclusion.

Hermogenes: How so?

403c

Socrates: I shall explain to you how I see all this. Tell me, then, what is the strongest bond for any living creature in order to ensure that it remains in some particular place – necessity or desire?

Hermogenes: Desire is a much stronger bond, Socrates.

Socrates: Now, don't you think that lots of people would escape from Hades if he did not bind those who go there with the strongest bond?

Hermogenes: Of course.

Socrates: So he binds them, it seems, by desire and not by necessity, since he binds them by the strongest bond.

Hermogenes: Apparently.

Socrates: Now, there are many desires, are there not?

Hermogenes: Yes.

403d

Socrates: So he binds them with the greatest desire of all if he is indeed to restrain people with the greatest bond.

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: Now, when someone believes they will become a better person by being with someone else, is there any greater desire than this?

Hermogenes: No, not at all, by Zeus, Socrates.

Socrates: So that's why we should maintain, Hermogenes, that none of the people who dwell there has any desire to leave, not even the Sirens themselves, for they too are under his spell, just

like all the others. This, it seems, is because Hades knows how to utter beautiful words, and, on account of this, the god is a perfect sophist and a great benefactor of those who are with him there, and he is also the cause of so much good to ourselves here. Because he is surrounded by so much in his own realm, he bears the name Pluto (wealth) for this reason.

403e

Socrates: Furthermore, he has no desire to be with us humans while we still hold onto our bodies, but he does associate with us once the soul is purified of all the badness and desires associated with the body. Don't you think then that he is a philosopher who appreciates that he may restrain people under these circumstances, having bound them with the desire for excellence? But while they are possessed of the excitement and madness of the body, not even his father, Cronus, would be able to hold them to himself by binding them with his famous shackles.

404a

Hermogenes: There seems to be something in what you are saying, Socrates.

404b

Socrates: So, Hermogenes, the name Hades is not really derived from the unseen (*aides*), but it is much more likely that the convention-setter called him Hades because of the fact that he knows (*eidenai*) all that is good.

Hermogenes: Very well. But what have we to say about *Dēmēter*, *Hēra*, *Apollo*, *Athena*, *Hephaestus*, *Ares*, and the other gods?

Socrates: *Dēmēter* is apparently so called because, like a mother (*mētēr*), she gives (*didousa*) the gift of food. *Hēra* is the lovely one (*eratē*) because Zeus is said to have married her for love. But perhaps the convention-setter, speaking in exalted terms, called the air (*aera*) *Hēra*, placing the beginning at the

end to conceal his intention. You would recognise this if you were to repeat the name Hera over and over. As for Pherephatta, this name is feared by many, and so too is the name Apollo because, it seems, of a lack of experience of the correctness of names. For they change Persephone to Phersephone (bringer of slaughter, pherein phonon), and this apparently terrifies them, although it points out the fact that the goddess is wise. For since things are in motion, wisdom would be that which fixes upon, or is in touch with, or has the ability to follow. So the goddess may rightly be called Pherephapa, or the like, because of her wisdom and her contact (epaphē) with that which is moving (pheromenon). That's why Hades, who is wise, associates with her, because she is a goddess of this sort. But nowadays people distort her name by assigning more importance to nice sound than to the truth, and so they call her Pherephatta. And as I say, in the case of Apollo, many people are fearful on account of the name of the god as though it discloses something terrible. Have you noticed this?

404e

Hermogenes: I have indeed, and what you are saying is true.

Socrates: But in my opinion the name is most beautifully suited to the power of the god.

Hermogenes: How so?

405a

Socrates: I shall try to explain my view on the matter. Indeed, there is no single name better suited to the four powers of the god so that it somehow encompasses them all and shows his musical, prophetic and medical power, and his skill in archery too.

Hermogenes: Please continue. Yes, you seem to be saying that the name is unusual.

Socrates: On the contrary, it harmonises well with the musical nature of the god. For in the first place, the purifications and purgations, both in medicine and in prophecy, and the fumigations with medicinal or oracular remedies, and the ablutions associated with these, and the sprinklings too, would all have one function – to render the person pure in body and in soul. Is this so?

405b

Hermogenes: It certainly is.

Socrates: Now, wouldn't Apollo be the god who purifies, cleanses (apolouōn) and delivers us (apoluōn) from such evils as these?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: In that case, in respect of the deliverances and cleansings, he may correctly be called 'Aploun' (he who cleanses), being a physician of maladies of this sort. In respect of prophecy, and what's true and what's simple (aplous), which are indeed the same, it would be correct to call him by the name that the people of Thessaly use, for they all call this god 'Aploun'. And because he is a master archer who is ever-darting (aei-bolōn), he is 'Aeiballōn' (everthrowing). And in respect of music, we need to understand that the letter 'a' often indicates 'together', and in this case it refers to movement together around the sky, around the poles as they are called, and also to harmony in song, which is called concord, because all these, as the experts in music and in astronomy tell us, move together at the same time, by a certain harmony. And this god Apollo supervises the harmony by moving them all together, for gods and for humans. So, just as our words for 'following' (akolouthon) and 'lying together' (akoitin) substitute the prefix 'a' for the prefix 'homo', so too, although he was called 'Omopolōn', we called him 'Apollo', adding an extra 'l' because the other name can mean something distressing. And even now

some people are still suspicious, and because they don't consider the power of the name in the correct manner, they are afraid that it is indicating some sort of destruction. In fact, as was said earlier, the name encompasses all the powers of the god – simplicity, ever-throwing, cleansing and moving together.

406a

Socrates: The Muses, and the realm of music in general, seem to derive their name from the word 'mōsthai' (to seek after) and from philosophic enquiry. Leto is so called because of the meekness of the god, as evidenced by her willingness (ethelēmona) to grant whatever anyone asks for. Or perhaps her name is Lētho, which is what many foreigners call her, because it seems her character is not harsh, but gentle and smooth (leion), and that's why they call her 'Lētho'. Artemis appears to be so called because of her soundness (artemes) and orderliness (kosmion) and her preference for virginity (parthenia), but it is just as likely that those who gave the goddess that name called her 'she who knows excellence' (aretēs histora). Or perhaps it was because of her hatred of procreation (aroton misēsasēs) involving a man and a woman. Or whoever gave the god her name did so for one of these reasons, or for all of them.

406b

Hermogenes: What about Dionysus and Aphrodite?

Socrates: My dear Hermogenes, you are asking me a big question. In fact, there is a serious way of explaining the names of these gods, and a playful one. You had best ask others for the serious account, but there is nothing to prevent us going over the playful one, for the gods are quite fond of playing. Indeed, Dionysus would be the one who gives (didous) wine (oinos), being playfully called 'Didoinysos'. As for wine, since most people who drink it believe (oieithai) that they are possessed of intelligence (nous) when they are not, it may correctly be called 'oionous'. There is no need to contradict Hesiod about

Aphrodite, and we can accept that she was so called because of her birth from foam (afrou).

406d

Hermogenes: But surely Socrates, you, an Athenian, won't forget about Athena, or indeed Hephaestus or Ares.

Socrates: That is hardly likely.

Hermogenes: Indeed not.

Socrates: Now, it is not difficult to explain the origin of her other name.

Hermogenes: Which is?

Socrates: We do call her 'Pallas', I presume?

Hermogenes: Of course.

406e

Socrates: Well, those who believe that this name was given because of her dancing in armour, would, in my opinion, be correct in their belief, for to raise oneself up from the ground or to lift something else in one's hands is to shake (pallein) or be shaken (palleisthai), to dance or be danced.

407a

Hermogenes: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Well, she is called Pallas because of this.

Hermogenes: And rightly so. But what about her other name?

Socrates: You mean Athena?

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: This, my friend, is a weightier matter. The ancients seem to have thought about Athena in much the same way as experts on Homer do nowadays. Indeed, most such commentators say that he represents Athena as 'nous' or thought (dianoia), while the person who devised her name

seems to have thought about her in much the same way, but he spoke of her in even more elevated terms as the intellect (noesis) of God (theou). He seems to say that she is ‘a theonoea’, using the letter ‘a’ in place of ‘e’, as foreigners do, also omitting the ‘i’ and the ‘s’. But perhaps this was not the reason, and perhaps he called her ‘Theonoēn’ (divine apprehension) because she apprehends (noousēs) the divine (theia) better than the others. And we cannot rule out the possibility that, wishing to say that this god was the embodiment of intellect (ēthēi noēsin), he called her ‘Ēthonoēn’, but he himself, or others afterwards, made a change to make the name prettier and called her ‘Athēnaa’.

407c

Hermogenes: What do you say about Hephaestus?

Socrates: Are you asking about the noble ‘knower of light’ (phaeos histora)?

Hermogenes: Probably.

Socrates: Isn’t it obvious to everyone then that this god is Phaistos with the letter ‘e’ added on?

Hermogenes: Quite likely, unless some further suggestion occurs to you, as it probably will.

Socrates: Well, so that I don’t suggest it, ask me about Ares.

Hermogenes: I’m asking.

407d

Socrates: Well, if you like, he could be ‘Ares’ in respect of his vigour (arren) and courage (andreion), or again, if you prefer, because he is hard and unbending, in other words ‘tough’ (arraton). Accordingly, ‘Ares’ would be an entirely appropriate name to call the god of war.

Hermogenes: Very much so.

Socrates: But, by the gods, let's leave the gods aside as I have become afraid of discussing them. Question me about anything else you like "so that we may see how" the horses of Euthyphro behave.

407e

Hermogenes: Yes, I shall do so, yet I have one more request of you about Hermes, since Cratylus says that I am no Hermogenes (offspring of Hermes). So let's try to investigate Hermes and understand this name, so that we may decide if Cratylus has a point.

Socrates: Well then, this name, 'Hermes', seems to be concerned with speech, and he seems to be an interpreter (hermēnea), a messenger, a thief, deceptive in his arguments, and a dealer, and all such activity involves the power of speech. Now, as we said previously, to speak (eirein) is to use words, and Homer often uses the word 'emēsato' which means to contrive. So, from both these usages, the convention-setter imposed upon us this name for the god who contrived (emēsato) speaking, which is 'eirein', and speech, as if to say "people, it is only right that you should call the god who contrived (emēsato) speech (eirein), Eirmēs." But nowadays we beautify the name, or so we think, and call him 'Hermes'. And Iris too seems to be named after speech (eirein) because she is a messenger.

408b

Hermogenes: Well, by Zeus, in that case I think Cratylus did well to say that I am no Hermogenes (offspring of Hermes), since when it comes to contriving speech, I am not up to much.

Socrates: And it is also reasonable, my friend, that Pan, with his twofold nature, is the son of Hermes.

408c

Hermogenes: How so?

Socrates: You know that speech indicates all things and keeps them circulating and moving, and it is twofold, true and false.

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: Now, the true speech is smooth and divine, dwelling on high among the gods, while the false speech dwells down here among the broad mass of humanity, and it is coarse and tragic, for most of the stories and falsehoods are based here and concern the tragic life.

Hermogenes: Indeed so.

Socrates: So it is only right that the one who reveals and is constantly (aei) moving (polōn) everything (pan) would be Pan, the goatherd (aipolos), the two-fold son of Hermes, with his upper parts smooth and his lower parts coarse and goat-like (tragoeidēs). And Pan, if he is indeed the son of Hermes, is either speech or the brother of speech, and it is no surprise that brother resembles brother. But as I said let's get away from discussion of the gods.

408d

Hermogenes: Yes, if you wish, Socrates, of gods of this sort at any rate. But is there any reason not to explain those of another sort, such as sun, moon, and stars, earth, ether, air, fire and water and the seasons and the year?

408e

Socrates: Well, you are asking a lot of me. Nevertheless, since it will please you, I am willing.

Hermogenes: It would please me, indeed.

Socrates: Well then, what would you like to deal with first? Or should we deal with the sun, the first one you mentioned?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

409a

Socrates: Well, I think the answer would become more obvious if we were to use the Doric version of the name. For they call the sun (helios) ‘Halios’. Now, it could be called Halios because it gathers (holizein) human beings together whenever it rises, or because it is constantly revolving (aei heilein) about the earth, or it could be because it seems to be responsible for the variegation (poikillein) of whatever arises from the earth, and ‘poikillein’ (to variegate) and ‘aioilein’ have the same meaning.

Hermogenes: What about the moon (selēnē)?

Socrates: It looks as if this name puts Anaxagoras under some pressure.

Hermogenes: Why is that?

409b

Socrates: It seems to be pointing out that his recent pronouncement that the moon gets its light from the sun is of more ancient date.

Hermogenes: How so?

Socrates: Selas (brightness) and phōs (light) presumably have the same meaning.

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: And if what Anaxagoras’ followers say is true, the light associated with the moon is presumably always both new (neon) and old (henon), for as the sun revolves about the moon, it constantly casts new (neon) light upon it, and there is also the old (henon) light of the previous month.

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: And many people call the moon ‘selanaia’.

Hermogenes: Indeed so.

Socrates: Because the moon always possesses new and old brightness, the most appropriate name by which to call it would be ‘selanoneoaeia’ (selon neon kai henon echei aei), but this is condensed down to ‘selanaia’.

409c

Hermogenes: Well, at least the name is poetic, Socrates, but what do you say about ‘month’ and ‘stars’?

Socrates: Month (mois) would correctly be called ‘meiēs’ from ‘meiousthai’ (to decrease). The stars (astra) seem to get their name from lightning (astrapēs), but because lightning turns our gaze upwards (anastrephei) it should be ‘anastrōpē’, which we call ‘astrapē’ nowadays to make it prettier.

Hermogenes: What about fire and water?

409d

Socrates: The word ‘pur’ (fire) perplexes me. Perhaps the Muse of Euthyphro has deserted me, or perhaps this word is just too difficult. Note the device I introduce in all situations like this where I am perplexed.

Hermogenes: Which is?

Socrates: I’ll tell you. Answer me this. Can you say how fire (pur) came to be so called?

Hermogenes: By Zeus, I cannot.

Socrates: Well, here is what I suspect; think about this. I notice that Greeks, especially those who live among non-Greeks, have adopted many names from them.

409e

Hermogenes: What of it?

Socrates: If someone were to investigate the reasonableness of these names by referring to the Greek language rather than the language from which they happen to derive, you know that they would be perplexed.

Hermogenes: Quite likely.

410a

Socrates: Look at this name ‘fire’ (pur), and decide whether or not it is non-Greek. Indeed, it is not easy to connect this word to the Greek language, and the Phrygians obviously use a slightly altered version, as they do also in the case of ‘water’ and ‘dog’ and many other names.

Hermogenes: Indeed so.

Socrates: Now, although something could be said about these words, we should not press this too far. So, on this basis, I am leaving ‘fire’ and ‘water’ aside. As for ‘air’ (aēr), Hermogenes, is it so called because it raises (airei) things up from the ground, or because it is always flowing (aei rei), or because wind arises when air flows? Indeed, the poets presumably refer to the winds as ‘blasts’ (aētai), so perhaps a poet says ‘blast-flow’ (aētorroun) as if he is saying ‘wind-flow’ (pneumatorroun). As for ‘ether’ (aithēr), my understanding is that it may rightly be called ‘aetheēr’ because it is always running (aei thei) and flowing (rei) about the air (aēr). Earth (gē) would better indicate its meaning if it were named ‘gaia’. Indeed, it would be correct to call ‘gaia’ a mother, as Homer does, for he uses ‘gegaasin’ to mean ‘to be born’ (gegenēsthai). Very well, what is next?

410c

Hermogenes: The seasons (hōrai), Socrates, and the two names for year, ‘eniautos’ and ‘etos’.

Socrates: If you wish to understand ‘the seasons’ (hōrai), the word should be spoken in the ancient Attic dialect as (horai), for they are seasons (horai) because they demarcate (horizein) winter and summer, the winds and the fruits of the earth. So they would rightly be called ‘horai’ because they demarcate (horizousai). The two words ‘eniautos’ and ‘etos’ for year are more than likely a single word. For that which leads whatever

grows or is born, in their turn, into the light, and scrutinises them within itself (en hautōi exetazei) is called 'eniautos' by some because this occurs in itself (en hautōi), and 'etos' by others because it scrutinises (etazei). This is just like the division of the name Zeus, as discussed previously, whom some call 'Zen', others 'Dia'. Although the account as a whole is 'that which scrutinises within itself' (en heautōi etazon), this single account, when spoken, is divided so that two names arise from the one account, 'eniautos' and 'etos'.

410e

Hermogenes: Well, Socrates, you are making great progress indeed.

Socrates: At this stage, I think I am apparently forging ahead in wisdom.

Hermogenes: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: You will say so even more in a moment.

411a

Hermogenes: Well, after this class of names I would gladly look at where precisely the correctness lies in the case of the noble names associated with excellence, such as 'wisdom' (phronēsis), 'comprehension' (sunesis) and 'justice' (dikaiosunē), and any others of that sort.

Socrates: Well, my friend you are stirring up a significant class of names. Nevertheless, since I have donned the lion's skin, I should not turn coward, but get on with the enquiry, it seems, into wisdom, comprehension, understanding and knowledge, and all those other noble names you speak of.

411b

Hermogenes: We certainly shouldn't quit before the job is done.

Socrates: And indeed, by the dog, I think that the intuition that occurred to me just now was not a bad one, and those ancient

personages who gave us these names were very much like most wise folk these days, who get dizzy because they perform so many about-turns in their search for the nature of things that are. And consequently, the actual things seem to them to be turning around and moving in every possible way. However, they do not blame this opinion upon their own internal condition. They believe, rather, that the actual things themselves are like this by nature, never stable or certain, constantly flowing and moving, always full of every sort of motion and change. This is what occurred to me in relation to all the names we are now considering.

411c

Hermogenes: How is that, Socrates?

Socrates: Perhaps you have not noticed the names just mentioned are applied as if the things named are moving, flowing, and changing in every way.

Hermogenes: No, that did not occur to me.

411d

Socrates: Well, to start with, the first one we mentioned is certainly named on the basis of such considerations as these.

Hermogenes: What name?

Socrates: ‘Wisdom’ (phronēsis) is intelligence (noēsis) of motion (phoras) and flow (rou). Or it may be interpreted as the advantage (onēsis) of motion (phoras), but in any case it is concerned with motion. Or, if you like, take ‘understanding’ (gnōme), which indicates enquiry (skepsis) and observation (nōmēsis) of generation (gonē), since ‘to enquire’ is the same as ‘to observe’. Or, if you prefer, the name ‘intelligence’ (noēsis) itself is the aspiration (hesis) for the new (neon), and the fact that things are new (neon) indicates that they are everchanging, and whoever gave us the name reveals this aspiration of the soul (neon hesis) to be neoesis (intelligence).

For *noēsis* was not originally so called; rather, two ‘e’s had to be spoken in place of the ‘ē’ to form ‘*noeesis*’. Sound-mindedness (*sōphrosunē*) is the preservation (*sōtēria*) of wisdom (*phronēsis*), which we have just looked at. And indeed, ‘knowledge’ (*epistēmē*) implies that the worthy soul follows (*hepei*) the moving things, without falling behind or running ahead, and so, having inserted an ‘e’, it should be called ‘*hepeistēmē*’. Accordingly, comprehension (*sunesis*), for its part, seems to be a sort of working out, for whenever someone is said ‘to comprehend’, it is really the same as being said ‘to know’, for ‘to comprehend’ means that the soul proceeds along with or goes along with (*sun iēmi*) things. Then again, ‘*sophia*’ (wisdom) indicates contact with motion.

412b

Socrates: The word is somewhat obscure and foreign, but we must remember that the poets often say of whatever proceeds quickly from its starting point that it rushes (*esuthē*). Indeed, one of the famous men of Sparta went by the name ‘*Sous*’ (rush), for that is what the Spartans call a rapid onslaught. So, ‘*sophia*’ indicates contact with this motion, as the motion of things that are. As for the word ‘good’ (*agathon*), this is supposed to apply to that which is admirable in all of nature. For since things that are in motion, some move rapidly while others move slowly. Now, not all that is fast is admirable, but part of it is admirable. So the designation ‘good’ (*agathon*) is given to the admirable (*agastos*) part of the fast (*thoos*).

412c

Socrates: Now, it is easy to conclude that justice (*dikaiosunē*) is the comprehension (*sunesis*) of what’s just (*dikaioi*), but the actual word ‘just’ (*dikaion*) presents a difficulty. For it seems, indeed, that most people agree up to a point but thereafter there is conflict. For those who believe that the universe is in motion assume that it is the sort of thing that can, for the most part, do nothing but provide space. But there is something

passing through all this on account of which everything that comes into being arises. This, they maintain, is extremely fast and subtle, for it would not be able to pass through everything without being repelled unless it was the subtlest, and so fast relative to the others that they appear to stand still.

412e

Socrates: Now, since it governs all the others by passing through (diaïon) them, it is correct to call it by this name, 'dikaion' (just), with the 'k' added for ease of pronunciation. So, up to this point, as I said just now, it is agreed by many people that this is what the just (dikaion) is. But I, Hermogenes, being persistent about this, have found out about all these matters in secret teachings; that this is what's just, and the cause, for the cause is that through which (di ho) anything arises, and someone stated that it is correct to call it Zeus (Dia) for that reason. But when, having heard this, I nevertheless ask gently, "If this is the case, my friend, what precisely is just?", they think, at that stage, that I am asking too many questions and going beyond all bounds. They tell me that I have done enough enquiring and then, wishing to satisfy me, they try a variety of arguments, but agree with one another no longer.

413b

Socrates: One says that the sun is the just, for this governs things by passing through (diaïonta) them and burning (kaonta) them. Yet, when I tell this to someone else, because I am delighted at hearing something so good, he laughs at me and asks if I believe there is no justice among us humans once the sun has set. So I persist, and ask him what he himself has to say, and he replies that the just is 'fire'. But this is not easy to understand. Another says that it is not the fire itself but the actual heat that is in the fire. But someone else says that all these suggestions are laughable, and that the just is what Anaxagoras says it is – namely, reason (nous). For reason, he says, is self-ruling, mixes with nothing, and orders all things as

it passes through everything. By then, my friend, I'm even more perplexed than I was when I set out to learn about the just and what precisely it is. In any case, the name appears to have been given for the reasons mentioned, and that's what our enquiry was about.

413d

Hermogenes: It seems to me, Socrates, that you have heard these suggestions from someone else and have not come up with them just now.

Socrates: What about the other names?

Hermogenes: You certainly did not hear those suggestions from someone else.

Socrates: Listen then, for perhaps I might actually mislead you into believing that the remaining suggestions are not something I have heard. So, what is left after justice? We have not yet dealt with courage. Now, it is obvious that injustice (adikia) is an impediment to that which passes through (diaion), whereas courage indicates that the name 'courage' is given in battle. Since what is flowing, a battle in what is would simply be the opposite flow, and if we omit the 'd' from the word 'andreia' (courage), the name 'anreia' (opposite flow) reveals this activity. Of course, courage is not a flow that is opposed to every other flow. It is, rather, opposed only to the flow that is contrary to what's just, otherwise courage would not be praiseworthy. And the words 'male' (arren) and 'man' (anēr) mean much the same as courage (andreia) in respect of upward flow (anō rhoē). It looks to me as if the word 'woman' (gunē) is intended to be 'birth' (gonē), while 'female' (thēlu) appears to be named from 'nipple' (thēlē), which in turn, Hermogenes, is so called because it makes things flourish (tethēlenai), like watered plants.

414a

Hermogenes: So it seems, Socrates.

Socrates: And, indeed, the word ‘flourish’ (thallein) itself seems to me to resemble the rapid sudden growth in the young. It is as if the name-giver has imitated this process in the name, which he forms by combining ‘to run’ (thein) and ‘to jump’ (hallesthai). But do you notice how I go off course once I come across smooth ground? And we do have many seemingly important matters left.

414b

Hermogenes: That’s true.

Socrates: One of which is to see what precisely the word ‘skill’ (technē) means.

Hermogenes: Very much so.

414c

Socrates: Doesn’t it indicate the possession (hexis) of reason (nous), once you remove the initial ‘t’ and insert an ‘o’ between the ‘ch’ and the ‘n’ and between the ‘n’ and the ‘ē’ to form ‘echonoē’?

Hermogenes: With some difficulty, Socrates.

Socrates: Heavens, don’t you know that the names that were originally given have, by now, been submerged by people who wish to make them more dramatic, attaching extra letters and taking them away for ease of pronunciation, twisting them this way and that, both to embellish them and because of the passage of time? Otherwise, don’t you think that the insertion of the letter ‘r’ into the word ‘katoptron’ (mirror) is unusual? I believe rather that this sort of thing is done by people who think nothing of the truth, but only of the shape of the mouth. And so they make lots of additions to the original names, finally making it impossible for anyone at all to understand what precisely the name means. So the Sphinx is called by that name rather than ‘phix’, and there are many other examples.

414d

Hermogenes: Yes, Socrates, that is how matters stand.

Socrates: Now, once anyone is allowed to add or delete whatever letters they wish from the names, the process becomes very easy, and any name may be associated with any activity.

414e

Hermogenes: That's true.

Socrates: True indeed, but I think you, a wise overseer, should protect measure and likelihood.

Hermogenes: I would like to do so.

415a

Socrates: And so would I, Hermogenes, but do not carry the verbal precision too far, blessed man, lest you “weaken my strength”. For I am approaching the summit that I spoke of, once, after ‘skill’, we have investigated ‘mechanism’. Indeed, ‘mechanism’ seems to me to indicate ‘extensive achievement’ (anein epi polu), for ‘mēkos’ (extent) somehow indicates the same thing as ‘epi polu’ (much). So, the word mechanism (mechanē) is composed of these two words, ‘anein’ (to accomplish) and ‘mēkos’ (extent) combined.

Socrates: But, as I said just now, we need to get to the summit of these deliberations, so we should investigate what the words ‘excellence’ and ‘badness’ actually mean. One of them is not yet clear to me, while the other seems to be obvious since it concurs with the previous examples. Indeed, since things are in motion, all that moves (ion) badly (kakōs) would constitute ‘badness’ (kakia). But when this happens in soul, and soul goes badly to things, this, for the most part, is what is generally called ‘badness’. But I think that what ‘going badly’ actually means is also clear from the word ‘cowardice’ (deilia), which we have overlooked and not yet dealt with, although we should have

dealt with it along with courage. I think we have also overlooked many others. Now, cowardice indicates a strong bond of the soul, for 'lian' (excess) is a sort of strength. So cowardice (deilia) would be the excessively great bond (desmos) of the soul, and it is bad, just as aporia (not proceeding) is bad, and so too, it seems, is anything that impedes movement and progress. So it appears that this 'going badly' is obviously a hindered and impeded motion, and any soul that possesses it becomes filled with badness. Now, if the name 'badness' is applied to this sort of thing, then excellence (aretē) would be the opposite of this, indicating, in the first place, 'proceeding easily' (euporia), and secondly that the flow of the good soul is always free. And so the unchecked and unimpeded flow has taken this name, it seems, but this name should really be 'aeireitēn' (ever flowing), but it has been condensed down and is called 'aretē'. Now, perhaps you may say that I am making this up, but I maintain that if what I said previously about badness is correct, then this suggestion about the name 'excellence' is correct too.

416a

Hermogenes: What then about the word 'bad', which was the basis of much of what you said previously? What does that word mean?

Socrates: I think, by Zeus, this word is somewhat strange and hard to understand, so in this case too I shall use that approach of mine.

Hermogenes: What approach?

Socrates: The approach whereby I declare that this word too is of non-Greek origin.

Hermogenes: Yes, you're probably right. So let's leave these words and try to look at 'noble' (kalon) and 'base' (aischron) and their reasonableness.

416b

Socrates: Well, what ‘base’ means seems quite obvious to me, and indeed this concurs with previous examples. For to me it looks as if whoever gave us the names is consistently censuring whatever impedes or restrains things in their flow. So, in this case, he has given this name ‘aischoroun’ to that which always (aei) restricts (ischei) the flow (roun), but nowadays it is condensed down and called ‘aischron’ (base).

Hermogenes: What about ‘beautiful’ (kalon)?

Socrates: This is more difficult to understand. Yet it does speak for itself, except that the letter ‘ō’ has been altered in accent and length.

Hermogenes: How so?

Socrates: This name seems to designate ‘thought’.

Hermogenes: How do you mean?

416c

Socrates: Come on, what do you think is responsible for calling by name each of the things that are? Is it not that which gave the names?

Hermogenes: Entirely so.

Socrates: And this would be thought, would it not, either of gods or of humans or both?

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: And is not that which called things by name the same as that which calls them now, namely thought?

Hermogenes: Apparently.

Socrates: Isn’t it also the case that whatever nous and thought bring about is praiseworthy, while anything they do not bring about is blameworthy?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

416d

Socrates: Does the practice of medicine bring about medical accomplishments, and the practice of carpentry the accomplishments of carpentry? What do you say?

Hermogenes: I think that this is so.

Socrates: Then, does the practice of naming (to kaloun) bring about beautiful accomplishments?

Hermogenes: Yes, it must.

Socrates: And, according to us, thought (dianoia) is that which names?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: So, this designation 'beautiful' (kalon) is, correctly, the name for wisdom (phronēseōs), which brings about the sort of accomplishments which we describe as beautiful, and which we welcome.

Hermogenes: Apparently.

416e

Socrates: Now, what names of this sort are still left?

417a

Hermogenes: Those that are related to the good and noble, such as 'beneficial', 'profitable', 'useful' and 'advantageous', and their opposites.

Socrates: Well, at this stage, I think you should be able to work out the word 'beneficial' for yourself, for it appears to be closely related to knowledge. Indeed, it is simply indicating the movement of the soul along with things, and whatever is enacted by such movement has, it seems, been called 'beneficial' and 'a benefit' (sumphora) because it moves (pheresthai) about (peri) with (sum) (summeripheresthai) things. The word

‘advantageous’ (kerdaleon) comes from ‘kerdos’ (gain), and restoring the ‘n’ instead of the ‘d’ in the word ‘kerdos’ to form ‘kernos’ reveals what it means, for it is ‘the good’, but in a different form. Indeed, because the good mingles with (kerannutai) and passes through everything, it was given a name (kernos) expressing this power, but a ‘d’ was inserted in place of the ‘n’ and it was spoken as ‘kerdos’ (gain).

417b

Hermogenes: What about ‘profitable’ (lusitelon)?

Socrates: It seems, Hermogenes, the name-giver does not use this word as traders do when their investment is released. I don’t think that this is what he means by profitable. Rather, because the good is the swiftest of all, it does not allow things to stand still, nor allow motion to come to an end, stop or pause. It continually sets the motion free, if there is any attempt to bring it to an end, and thus renders the motion unceasing and undying. It is in this sense, I think, that the good is declared to be profitable, for that which releases (luon) the end (telos) of motion is called ‘lusiteloun’ (profitable). ‘Beneficial’ (ōphelimon) is a foreign word which is often used by Homer in the form ‘ophellein’, and this designates ‘increasing’ or ‘making’.

417d

Hermogenes: What have we to say about the opposites of these?

Socrates: Those that are simple negations of these words do not, in my opinion, require an explanation.

Hermogenes: What are those?

Socrates: ‘Unbeneficial’, ‘useless’, ‘unprofitable’ and ‘disadvantageous’.

Hermogenes: That’s true.

Socrates: But ‘harmful’ and ‘hurtful’ do require an explanation.

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: Well, ‘harmful’ (blaberon) means that which harms (blapton) the flow (roun), while ‘harm’ (blapton), for its part, indicates wanting (boulomenon) to grasp (haptein), and ‘to grasp’ is actually the same as ‘to bind’, which the name-giver consistently censures. Now, that which wishes (boulomenon) to grasp (haptein) the flow (roun) would most correctly be ‘boulapteroun’, but it looks to me as if this has been called ‘blaberon’ to make it sound nicer.

Hermogenes: Socrates, what elaborate names you come up with! In fact, you seemed to me to be using your mouth just now as a flute to render the prelude to the hymn of Athena as you pronounced ‘boulapteroun’.

418a

Socrates: Those who gave us the name are responsible for this, Hermogenes, not I.

Hermogenes: That’s true, but what about ‘hurtful’? What would this be?

Socrates: Yes, ‘hurtful’, what precisely would that be? Observe, Hermogenes, how true my statement was when I said that by adding and removing letters people significantly alter the intentions of words, so that by making very minor alterations they sometimes make words indicate their direct opposites. Take for instance the word ‘deon’ (obligation).

418b

Socrates: Indeed, I had this in mind just now, and I was reminded of it by what I was just about to say to you. Our lovely modern language has actually distorted the words ‘deon’ (obligation) and ‘zēmiōdes’ (harmful) to indicate their direct opposites, thus concealing what the word intends, whereas the ancient language reveals what both words intend.

Hermogenes: How so?

Socrates: I'll tell you. You know that our ancestors made much use of the letters 'i' and 'd', especially the women, who are most protective of the ancient language. But nowadays people turn 'i' and the 'e' into 'ē', and the 'd' into 'z', as these give a loftier sound.

418c

Hermogenes: How so?

Socrates: For example, people nowadays call 'day' 'hēmera', whereas ancient speakers called it 'himera' in some cases, and 'hemera' in others.

Hermogenes: Quite so.

Socrates: Now, are you aware that only the ancient name reveals the thinking of the name-giver? For when, from darkness, light has arisen, people are glad and they long (himeirousin) for this, and so they call it 'himera'.

418d

Hermogenes: Apparently so.

Socrates: But nowadays the name is so dramatised that you would not understand what this word means. In fact, some people think that day (hēmera) makes things gentle (hēmera) and has this name for this reason.

Hermogenes: I believe so.

Socrates: And you also realise that the people of old called a yoke 'duogon' rather than 'zugon'.

Hermogenes: Certainly.

418e

Socrates: And although the word 'zugon' reveals nothing, that which binds a pair together for the purposes of drawing something is correctly given the name 'duogon'. But now it is

just 'zugon'. Indeed, there are very many more instances of this.

Hermogenes: Apparently.

Socrates: In the same way, the word 'deon' (obligation), thus spoken, indicates initially the direct opposite of all the other words associated with the good. For although obligation is a form of good, it appears to be a shackle or an impediment to motion as if it is actually akin to harm.

Hermogenes: Very much so, Socrates, it does appear that way.

419a

Socrates: Not if you make use of the ancient name, which is much more likely to be correct than the modern one. In fact, it will be in agreement with our previous words for good if, in place of the 'e', you restore the 'i', as in the ancient word. For the word 'diion' (going through) indicates the good that the name-giver praises, whereas 'deon' (shackle) does not. Accordingly, whoever gave us the names does not contradict himself, and 'obligation', 'useful', 'profitable', 'advantageous', 'good', 'beneficial' and 'easy' all appear the same. They are indicating, with different names, that which brings order and that which moves, which is consistently praised, while that which restricts and binds is censured. And indeed, in the case of 'harmful' (zēmiōdes), if you restore the 'd' in place of the 'z', as in the ancient word, it will be evident that this name (dēmiōdes) applies to that which binds (dounti) motion (ion).

419b

Hermogenes: What about 'pleasure' and 'pain' and 'desire' and names of that sort, Socrates?

Socrates: These don't look particularly difficult, Hermogenes. For pleasure (hēdonē) has this name because it is the activity that tends to our advantage (hē onēsis), but a 'd' is inserted so that it is called 'hēdonē' (pleasure) rather than 'hēonē'. Pain (lupē) seems to get its name from the breakdown (dialusis)

which the body undergoes when experiencing pain.

419c

Socrates: ‘Grief’ (ania) is that which impedes motion (ienai). ‘Suffering’ (algēdōn) looks to me like a foreign word which comes from the word ‘grieving’ (algeinos). ‘Distress’ (odunē) seems to be so called from the entering in (endusis) of pain. In the case of ‘vexation’ (achthēdōn), it is evident to all that the word bears a resemblance to a weight (achtos or baros) imposed upon motion. ‘Joy’ (chara) seems to have been so called from the relaxed and easy motion of the soul. The word ‘delight’ comes from ‘delightful’ (terpnon), which is so called from the gradual motion (herpsis) of the soul, which resembles breath (pnoē) and is rightly called ‘herpnoun’, but over time this has been called ‘terpnon’. The word ‘euphrosunē’ (cheerfulness) requires no further explanation since it is obvious to all that this name derives from the good disposition (eu sumpheresthai) of the soul towards things. Although the right name is ‘euphrosunē’, we call it ‘euphrosunē’ (cheerfulness).

419d

Socrates: ‘Desire’ (epithumia) presents no difficulty either, for this name was obviously given to the power that enters into (epi) the heart (thumos), while ‘thumos’ would get this name from the raging (thusis) and seething (zesis) of the soul. The name ‘himeros’ (longing) is given to the flow (rous) which draws the soul most of all, for it rushes (hiemenos) forth (rhei) and is sent towards (ephiemenos) things, and in so doing it draws the soul forcibly due to the intent of the flow, and because of all this power it is called ‘himeros’ (longing). Now, ‘yearning’ (pothos) indicates that it is not a desire or flow for that which is present, but for that which is elsewhere (allothi pou ontos) or absent (apontos), and so it is then called ‘pothos’ (yearning). So, when someone desires that which is present, this is called ‘longing’, but the same desire is called ‘yearning’ (pothos) when it is for that which is not present.

420b

Socrates: ‘Love’ (erōs) has this name because it flows in from outside, and the flow itself is not native to the person who has it, but is brought in from outside through the eyes. That is why in ancient times it was called ‘esros’ (influx), from the inflowing (esrein), for we used the short ‘o’ then rather than a long ‘ō’, but nowadays it is called ‘erōs’ because of the substitution of these letters. Are there any other names you think we should consider?

Hermogenes: What about ‘opinion’ and words of that sort? How do these appear to you?

Socrates: ‘Opinion’ (doxa) is either named after the pursuit (diōxis) in which the soul engages when pursuing the knowledge of how things are, or, as is more likely, the shooting (bolē) of the bow (toxon). At any rate, the word ‘thought’ (oiēsis) concurs with this word, for this seems to be pointing to the motion (oisis) of the soul towards all things, as each of the things that are, actually is. Similarly, ‘deliberation’ (boulē) is somehow ‘shooting’ (bolē), while ‘wishing’ (boulesthai) indicates being sent towards (ephiesthai) something, as does ‘deliberating’ (bouleuesthai). All these words appear to follow from ‘opinion’ (doxa) and to bear a resemblance to ‘shooting’ (bolē), as do their opposites. And so ‘lack of deliberation’ (aboulia) seems to be ‘missing the mark’ (atuchia), as if someone failed to shoot or hit whatever was meant, intended or desired.

420d

Hermogenes: At this stage, Socrates, you seem to be quickening the pace.

Socrates: Yes, because the end is now in sight. But I would still like to explain ‘compulsory’ and ‘willing’ because these come next. Now ‘willing’ (hekousion), by this name, would be indicating that which yields and does not resist, but, as I say, is yielding to motion (eikon toi ionti) that accords with our will.

On the other hand, that which is compulsory and which resists, being contrary to our will, would be associated with error and ignorance and would be like proceeding through a ravine (agkē) which is hard to traverse, rough and overgrown, so that it impedes motion. Accordingly, it may have been called ‘compulsory’ (anagkaion), because it is like a journey through a ravine (agkē). So, as long as the strength is still available to us, let’s keep using it, and you should not give up your questioning.

421a

Hermogenes: I’ll ask then about the most important and exalted words, ‘truth’, ‘falsehood’ and ‘being’, and ‘name’, the very word with which our present argument is concerned, and why it has this name.

Socrates: Do you use the word ‘maiesthai’?

Hermogenes: I do, it means ‘to enquire’.

Socrates: Well, ‘name’ seems to be a combined word, coming from a phrase that says that “this is being which is the subject of enquiry”. You would recognise this better from the adjective ‘named’ (onomaston), for in that case the word clearly says that this is being (on) about which (hou) there is enquiry (masma). The word ‘truth’ is like the others, for the divine motion of being seems to be referred to by the word ‘truth’ (alētheia), which indicates ‘divine wandering’ (theia alē). ‘Falsehood’ (pseudos) is the opposite of motion, for once again that which is restrained and compelled to be still is censured and likened to people who are asleep (katheudos), but the insertion of the ‘ps’ hides the intention of the name.

421b

Socrates: ‘Being’ (on) and ‘existence’ (ousia) are in agreement with ‘truth’ (alēthes), but the letter ‘i’ has been removed, for ‘being’ (on) indicates ‘moving’ (ion) and ‘not being’ (ouk on) indicates ‘not moving’ (ouk ion), and that indeed is what some

people call it.

421c

Hermogenes: I think, Socrates, that you have split these words apart most courageously, but what if someone were to ask you about this word ‘ion’ (moving) and also ‘rheon’ (flowing) and ‘doun’ (binding), and the correctness of these names?

Socrates: What answer would we give? Is that what you mean?

Hermogenes: Very much so.

Socrates: Well, we adopted one approach to answering such a question earlier, and it seemed to make sense.

Hermogenes: What approach?

421d

Socrates: Saying that any word we do not recognise must be of non-Greek origin. Now it may well be true that some of these words are indeed of this sort, but on the other hand it could also be the case that our first words are so old they are undiscovered. Indeed, because words are distorted in all sorts of ways, it would be no surprise if our ancient language did not differ at all from the modern foreign tongue.

Hermogenes: Yes, that’s a reasonable suggestion.

Socrates: Yes, quite likely. However, “once the game is on, no excuses are accepted”, so we should press on eagerly with our enquiry. But we should reflect that if someone repeatedly asks what a name is composed of, and then goes on to ask what the components themselves are composed of, and keeps on doing this without stopping, won’t the person who has to answer eventually be forced to give up?

421e

Hermogenes: I think so.

422a

Socrates: So, when would it be right to give up and stop? Would it not be when we arrive at those names that are like elements of the other words and names? For if they are indeed elements, it is presumably no longer right to suppose they are constituted from other names. For example, we said just now that ‘agathon’ (good) was a combination of ‘agastos’ (admirable) and ‘thoos’ (fast). And we might say that ‘thoos’ is, in turn, composed of some other words. But if we ever get to a word that is not composed of other words, we would be right to maintain at that stage that this word is already an element, and we should no longer refer this back to other words.

422b

Hermogenes: Yes, I think you’re right.

Socrates: So is it perhaps the case that those very names you are asking about are elements, and it is therefore necessary to consider where the correctness lies by some other means?

Hermogenes: Quite likely.

422c

Socrates: Likely indeed, Hermogenes. At any rate, all our previous names appear to have been broken down into these elements. And if this is the case, as I think it is, then please continue the joint investigation along with me, in case I start talking nonsense as I explain the correctness of the first names.

Hermogenes: Speak on and I shall join you in the enquiry to the best of my ability.

Socrates: I think you agree with me that there is but one kind of correctness belonging to any name, first or subsequent, and that names do not differ in being names.

Hermogenes: Very much so.

422d

Socrates: But at least in the case of the names we have gone through, the correctness consisted, more or less, in the

intention to show what some particular thing is like.

Hermogenes: Of course.

Socrates: And this must be the case for the first names and for the subsequent names too, if they are indeed to be names.

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: But the subsequent names, it seems, were able to accomplish this through the first ones.

Hermogenes: Apparently.

Socrates: Well then, in the case of the first names which are no longer based upon other names, if they are to be names, how can they, as best they can, make things as apparent to us as possible? Answer this question for me. If we had neither voice nor tongue, but we wished to indicate things to one another, would we not act like people who cannot speak and try to make signs with our hands and head and the rest of our body?

422e

Hermogenes: What else could we do, Socrates?

423a

Socrates: So, if we wished to indicate something above or light, I think we might raise a hand to the heavens indicating the nature of that thing; and in the case of something below or heavy, we might gesture towards the earth. If we wished to indicate a running horse or some other animal, I am sure we would make our bodies and our behaviour resemble theirs as much as we possibly could.

Hermogenes: Yes, I think this must be so.

Socrates: For this, I believe, is how any indication of anything would arise. It would, it seems, occur by bodily imitation of whatever we wish to indicate.

423b

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: But when we wish to give an indication with our voice, tongue and mouth, won't something that emerges from these be an indication of the thing for us, once an indication of anything has been produced by means of these three?

Hermogenes: That seems necessary to me.

Socrates: So a name, it seems, is an imitation, by voice, of that which is imitated, and whoever is imitating with the voice is naming whatever is being imitated.

Hermogenes: I think so.

423c

Socrates: But, by Zeus, my friend, I don't think I am yet expressing this correctly.

Hermogenes: Why not?

Socrates: Because we could be forced to accept that those who imitate sheep and cocks and other animals are naming whatever creatures they are imitating.

Hermogenes: That's true.

Socrates: Now, do you think it is correct to accept this?

Hermogenes: No, I do not. But, Socrates, what sort of an imitation would a name be?

423d

Socrates: Well, firstly, when imitating things just as we do when using music, I don't think we are imitating them by using names, even though we are in that case imitating them by using our voice. Secondly, when we imitate the things that music imitates, I don't think we are naming them. What I am saying is this. Does each thing have sound and shape, and in many cases, colour too?

Hermogenes: Certainly.

Socrates: Well, no skill in naming seems to be involved in imitating these properties. In fact, the relevant skill for these is either music or painting. Is this so?

Hermogenes: Yes.

423e

Socrates: What about this, then? Does it not seem to you that each thing also has an essence, just as it has colour and the other properties we just mentioned? Firstly, in the case of colour and sound, is there not an essence of each, and also of anything else to which being may properly be attributed?

Hermogenes: I think so.

Socrates: Well then, if someone were able to imitate this very essence belonging to each thing by means of letters and syllables, wouldn't he be indicating what each thing is? Isn't this so?

424a

Hermogenes: It certainly is.

Socrates: And what about the person who is able to do this? What would you say this person is, just as you said the previous two were the musician and the painter?

Hermogenes: I think, Socrates, that this is the very person we have been looking for all along, the namer.

Socrates: So, if this is true, we should, it seems, enquire at this stage into those names you asked about, 'flow' (rhoē), 'going' (ienai), 'holding' (schesis), and whether or not the namer grasps the being of these by means of the letters and syllables, so as to imitate the essence.

424b

Hermogenes: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Come on then, let's see whether these are the only first names or whether there are many others too.

Hermogenes: Well, I think that there are others.

Socrates: Quite likely. But what would be the manner of division from which the imitator sets about imitating? Or, since the imitation of the essence happens to consist of syllables and letters, would it not be most correct to divide off the elements first, just as those who deal with rhythms first separate off the powers of the elements, then the powers of the syllables, and only at that stage do they investigate the rhythms?

424c

Hermogenes: Yes.

Socrates: Accordingly, should we too first separate off the vowels, then, on the basis of their different kinds, the consonants and the mutes, as the experts on these matters presumably call them?

Socrates: Should we also do the same for those that are neither vowels nor mutes, and for the vowels themselves that differ in kind from one another? Once we have properly separated these off, we should proceed to give names to everything that needs to be named, provided there are names to which they are all referred back, just as words are referred back to letters. From these names it is possible to look at the things and see where these come from, and whether there are kinds among the things in the same way that there are among the letters.

424d

Socrates: Once we have examined all these aright, we shall know how to apply each letter based upon likeness, whether one letter should be applied to one thing, or many should be combined. In this we are like painters, who, wishing to create a likeness, sometimes apply purple just by itself, sometimes some other pigment, and on occasion they mix many pigments – as when, for instance, they wish to produce a flesh-coloured pigment or something of that sort, presumably applying the

particular pigment that the relevant image seems to require.

424e

Socrates: We too shall apply the letters to the things in this way, one letter to one thing when that's what seems to be required, or combining many letters to form what are called syllables, or indeed combining syllables to form nouns and verbs. Or again, we might construct a great and noble whole from the nouns and verbs, forming a sentence by means of the skill of naming or rhetoric, or whatever the skill may be, just as in the other example we constructed the animal by means of artistic skill. Of course, I am not speaking of ourselves; I got carried away by the argument. The ancients combined the letters in the way in which they are now combined, while we, for our part, if we are to arrive at a systematic understanding of all this, should, once the words have been divided in this way, see whether or not the first names and the subsequent ones too are correctly assigned.

425b

Socrates: Otherwise, my dear Hermogenes, the connection of words to things will be poor and unsystematic.

Hermogenes: By Zeus, Socrates, you may well be right.

Socrates: What about this? Do you believe that you could divide these words in this way yourself? I know I could not.

Hermogenes: In that case, I certainly couldn't do it.

Socrates: So, should we leave it at that, or would you prefer that we do the best we can, make an effort, and see if we can get even a little insight into these matters? Earlier we announced to the gods that we knew nothing of the truth and were really presenting the opinions of us humans about them. Should we do the same thing now and proceed by telling ourselves that if we, or anyone else at all, are to divide these words, they should be divided as we have described, while we now need to apply

ourselves to these matters to the best of our so-called ability? Do you agree, or what do you say?

425c

Hermogenes: I couldn't agree more, Socrates.

425d

Socrates: Although it may appear absurd, Hermogenes, that things become manifest by being imitated with letters and syllables, this must nevertheless be so. For we do not have any better principle upon which we may base the truth of the first names, unless you would prefer the method adopted by tragedians when they get into difficulties and use stage machinery to introduce the gods. We could act similarly and solve our problem by saying that the gods gave us the first names, and they are correct for this reason. So, is this the best argument we have? Or is our argument that we have acquired these names from some non-Greek peoples, and non-Greeks are more ancient peoples than ourselves? Or is it impossible to investigate these words because they are so ancient, and does the same hold for the foreign words?

426a

Socrates: Indeed, these would all be very elegant evasions by someone who was unwilling to present an argument as to where the correctness of the first names lies. And it is presumably impossible for someone, who for whatever reason knows nothing about the correctness of the first names, to know about the subsequent names which are explained by first names which he knows nothing about. It is obvious, rather, that anyone who claims to be knowledgeable about the subsequent names, must first and foremost be able to explain the first names, or rest assured he will already be talking nonsense about the subsequent ones. Do you disagree?

426b

Hermogenes: Not at all, Socrates.

Socrates: Well, any observations of mine about the first names really seem presumptuous and absurd. Now, although I am prepared to share them with you, if you wish, you should also make an effort to share with me if you have anything better.

Hermogenes: I shall do so, but you should take courage and speak on.

426c

Socrates: Well, in the first place, the letter 'r' appears to me like an instrument of all motion, although we have not explained why 'motion' (kinēsis) has this name. Now 'kinēsis' (motion) should obviously be 'hesis' (going toward), for in ancient times we did not use the letter 'ē' but the letter 'e'. And this word 'kinēsis' (motion) starts with 'kiein', a foreign word that means 'to go'. So we would find that the ancient word corresponding to the modern word would more correctly be 'hesis'. But nowadays, from the foreign word 'kiein' and from the change of 'e' to 'ē' and the insertion of 'n', it has been called 'kinēsis', although the word should be 'kieinēsis'. The word rest (stasis) means the negation of motion, but to make it sound nicer, it has been called 'stasis'. The letter 'r', as I was saying, seemed to the name-giver to be a good instrument of motion for the purposes of imitating movement, and he often uses it accordingly. Firstly, in the words flowing (rhein) and flow (rhoē), themselves, he imitates their movement by means of this letter. Then, in the word 'tromos' (trembling), 'trechein' (running) and in such verbs as 'krouein' (striking), 'thrauein' (breaking), 'ereikein' (tearing), 'thruptein' (crushing), 'kermatizein' (crumbling), 'rhumbein' (whirling), he gives expression to all these, for the most part, by means of the letter 'r'. For I think he observed that with this letter, the tongue is least at rest and most agitated, which seems to be the reason why he used this letter for these words. Again, he uses the letter 'i' for everything subtle that passes through all things. That is why he imitates 'ienai' (going)

and 'hiesthai' (rushing) by the letter 'i', just as he uses 'ph' and 'ps' and 's' and 'z', which involve a lot of breath, to imitate everything of this sort, in words such as 'psuchron' (cold), 'zeon' (boiling), 'seiesthai' (shaking) and 'seismos' (shock). Indeed, the giver of names, whenever he imitates anything that involves wind, always appears to introduce letters of this sort. Then again, it looks as if he regarded the force of the compression and pressure of the tongue associated with 'd' and 't' as useful for imitating 'binding' (desmos) and 'stopping' (stasis). Noticing that the tongue glides most of all in pronouncing 'l', he imitated this in the words 'leia' (smooth), in the word 'gliding' (olisthanein) itself, and the words 'liparon' (sleek) and 'kollōdes' (viscous), and various other words like these. By the force of the letter 'g', which opposes the gliding of the tongue, he imitated 'glischros' (sticky), 'glukus' (sweet) and 'gloiōdes' (glutinous).

427c

Socrates: Again, observing that the letter 'n' is sounded within, he gave us the words 'endon' (inside) and 'entos' (within), producing a likeness to these by means of the letters, and again he used 'a' for the word 'mega' (large) and 'ē' for 'mēkos' (length) because these letters are long. Because he needed the letter 'o' to indicate roundness, he mixed a lot of this letter into the word 'gongulos' (round). In this way, the convention-setter, it appears, made the other letters into resemblances, making an indication or a name for each of the things that are with letters and syllables, and from these he then compounded the rest of the names by a process of imitation using these names. This, as I see it, Hermogenes, is what it means for names to be correct, unless Cratylus has an alternative suggestion.

427d

Hermogenes: Well, Socrates, as I said at the outset, Cratylus often bothers me quite a lot, maintaining that there is a correctness of names without clarifying what it is, and so I'm unable to decide whether his lack of clarity when speaking

about them is intentional or unintentional. So, Cratylus, tell me now, with Socrates present, if you accept what he says about names or do you have something better to offer? And if you have, do please tell us so that you may either learn from Socrates, or else instruct both of us.

427e

Cratylus: What's this Hermogenes? Do you think it is easy to learn any subject so quickly, or to teach it either, especially a subject like this which seems to be one of the most important?

428a

Hermogenes: By Zeus, I do not. But I think that Hesiod put it well when he said that “even a little added to a little is worthwhile”. So if you are able to make even a little progress, please make the effort and be kind to Socrates, as you should, and to me too.

Socrates: What is more, Cratylus, I myself would not be insistent upon anything I have said. I have only expressed what occurred to me in the enquiry with Hermogenes, and so you should take heart, and if you have something better to suggest then rest assured I shall accept it. In fact, I would not be surprised if you had a better suggestion. I believe you have investigated such matters yourself and have learned from others too. Indeed, if you do have a better suggestion, please enrol me too as one of your pupils in the subject of the correctness of names.

428b

Cratylus: Well, Socrates, as you say, I certainly have studied these matters, and I might well make a student of you. But I fear that the exact opposite is the case, and it occurs to me to address you as Achilles addressed Ajax in the Prayers, where he says: ^{428c} Son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, Aias, lord of the people: ^{428c} all that you have said seems spoken after my own mind. Indeed, Socrates, you seem to be delivering prophetic

utterances that are more or less after my own mind, whether you have been inspired by Euthyphro or some other Muse who has long dwelt unnoticed within you.

428d

Socrates: My dear Cratylus, I myself have long been amazed at my own wisdom, and doubtful of it too. So I think it is necessary to reconsider anything I have said. Indeed, the most grievous deception of all is self-deception. For when the deceiver is never far away but is everpresent, what could be more terrible? We should then, it seems, constantly revisit what has been said previously, and attempt, as the poet says, “to look forwards and backwards simultaneously”. And so we should now look at what we ourselves have said.

428e

Socrates: We maintain that the correctness of a name consists in the fact that it indicates the sort of thing it names. Should we declare that this is an adequate statement?

Cratylus: Very much so, Socrates, in my opinion.

Socrates: So names are spoken for the purposes of instruction?

Cratylus: Certainly.

Socrates: And should we say that this is a skill and that there are exponents of this skill?

Cratylus: Certainly.

Socrates: Who are they?

429a

Cratylus: The very people you spoke of at the outset – the convention-setters.

Socrates: Now, does this skill arise in people in the same way as the other skills, or does it not? What I mean to ask is, in the case of painters, some are better while others are worse, are they not?

Cratylus: Of course.

Socrates: Don't the better painters produce better works of art while the others produce inferior works? And doesn't the same hold for builders; some construct fine houses, others poorer ones?

Cratylus: Yes.

429b

Socrates: Now, do some convention-setters produce fine products, others inferior products?

Cratylus: No, I don't think this is still the case here.

Socrates: So you don't think that some conventions are better, while others are inferior?

Cratylus: Indeed not.

Socrates: Neither then do you accept, it seems, that one name is worse while another is better?

Cratylus: Indeed not.

Socrates: So all names are given correctly?

Cratylus: Well, those that are, really are names, at any rate.

429c

Socrates: What about the question that was asked earlier about our friend Hermogenes here? Is this not his name, unless he happens to have been born of Hermes, or does he have that name although it is incorrect?

Cratylus: In my opinion, Socrates, he does not have that name, although it seems that he has. This name belongs to someone else who possesses the appropriate nature.

Socrates: When someone says that this is Hermogenes, is he not even lying? Indeed, could there even be a statement that "this is Hermogenes" if he is not Hermogenes?

Cratylus: How do you mean?

429d

Socrates: Is it totally impossible to speak falsehood? Is this the point of your argument? For there are lots of people, nowadays and of old, who say this, my dear Cratylus.

Cratylus: Indeed so, Socrates. How could anyone, saying whatever is said, not speak what is? But to speak falsehood is not to speak what is. Is this not the case?

429e

Socrates: Your argument is too clever for me at my age, my friend. Nevertheless, answer me this. Do you think it is impossible to speak falsehood but possible to state it?

Hermogenes: No, I don't think it is possible to state it either.

Socrates: Is it possible, then, to say or declare it? For instance, if someone who met you abroad were to take you by the hand and say, "Greetings stranger from Athens, Hermogenes, son of Smikrion", would that person be speaking all this, or stating it, or saying it, or declaring it to Hermogenes here and not to you, or to nobody?

Cratylus: In my opinion, Socrates, the person would be uttering all this at random.

430a

Socrates: A welcome response indeed. Now, would whatever is uttered be true or false, or would some of it be true, some of it false? A response to this would suffice.

Cratylus: As I see it, such a person is making noises, acting in vain, like someone banging a brass pot.

Socrates: Well, let's see if we can somehow come to an agreement, Cratylus. Would you maintain that the name is one thing, while that of which it is the name is something else?

Cratylus: I would.

430b

Socrates: Would you agree that the name is an imitation of the thing?

Cratylus: Most emphatically.

Socrates: Wouldn't you also say that paintings, in a different way, are also imitations of certain things?

Cratylus: Yes.

Socrates: Bear with me then, for I may well be misunderstanding what you are saying, although you may perhaps be right. Is it possible to allocate or apply both these imitations, the paintings and those names, to the things of which they are imitations?

430c

Cratylus: It is.

Socrates: Consider this question first. Is it possible to assign the image of a man to a man, and that of a woman to a woman, and so on?

Cratylus: Certainly.

Socrates: Isn't it also possible to do the opposite and assign the image of the man to the woman, and that of the woman to the man?

Cratylus: Indeed so.

Socrates: And are both these allocations correct, or only the first?

Cratylus: Only the first.

Socrates: The one that presumably assigns to each the image that is appropriate to it, or is like it.

Cratylus: I think so.

430d

Socrates: Well, since you and I are friends, to avoid a dispute over words I'll explain what I mean. I call the first example of both imitations, with paintings or with names, correct, my friend, while in the case of names I call it both correct and true. In the second example, I call the unlike assignment and application incorrect, and I call it false too when it involves names.

430e

Cratylus: That may well be so, Socrates, in the case of paintings but not in the case of names; they are always of necessity correctly assigned.

Socrates: How do you mean? What's the difference between the two? Is it not possible for me to meet a man, say to him, "This is your portrait", and show him what happens to be his own image, or what happens to be that of a woman? And by 'show' I mean bring to his visual awareness.

Cratylus: Certainly.

Socrates: Why, then, is it not possible for me to meet the same man once more and say, "This is your name"? The name is also presumably an image, as is the painting. So my question is, why can't I say to him, "This is your name", and after this, again, bring before his sense of hearing what happens to be his own image and say 'man', and then an image of what happens to be a female human being, and say 'woman'? Don't you think this is possible, and sometimes happens?

431a

Cratylus: I am prepared to agree with you, Socrates. Let it be so.

Socrates: You are doing well, my friend, if this is indeed so, for there is no longer any need to argue over this. If there is an allocation of this sort, in this case too we might wish to call the first of these examples 'speaking the truth', and the second 'speaking falsehood'.

431b

Socrates: But if this is how matters stand and it is possible to allocate names incorrectly, or not assign appropriate names to each object, or sometimes assign inappropriate names, then the same argument would apply also to verbs. And if verbs and nouns can be applied in this way, the same must hold for sentences, since sentences are, I presume, a combination of these two. What do you say, Cratylus?

431c

Cratylus: Just that. I think you are right.

Socrates: Now if we liken the first names to sketches, then it is possible, as in paintings, to assign all of the appropriate colours and shapes, or then again, not all of them, for some may be omitted, or some may be added in, or be excessive or overdone. Isn't this so?

Cratylus: It is.

Socrates: Now whoever assigns all of them assigns good sketches and images, while anyone who adds anything in or subtracts anything still produces sketches and images, but they are inferior. Isn't this so?

431d

Cratylus: Yes.

Socrates: What about the person who imitates the being of things by means of syllables and letters? By the same argument, won't the image, which is the name, be good provided he assigns everything that is appropriate? But if he ever omits something or adds something in, an image will be produced but it will not be good. So, won't some of the names be well produced, while others will be badly produced?

Cratylus: Perhaps so.

431e

Socrates: So perhaps one artificer of names will be good, while another will be bad?

Cratylus: Yes.

Socrates: And the name of this artificer is 'convention-setter'.

Cratylus: Yes.

Socrates: So perhaps, by Zeus, as with other skills, one convention-setter will be good, another bad, if we accept those previous conclusions.

Cratylus: Quite so. But you see, Socrates, whenever we assign these letters, 'a' or 'b', or any of the elements, to the names by means of the skill of grammar, and we omit or add in or transpose anything, we do not write the name incorrectly; rather, we do not even write it at all. Once it undergoes any of these alterations it is immediately different.

432a

Socrates: Well, Cratylus, are we perhaps not conducting this enquiry in the right way?

Cratylus: How so?

Socrates: Perhaps, whatever must of necessity be some number, or not be anything, might be characterised as you describe, just as ten itself, or any other number you please, immediately becomes a different number once you subtract anything or add anything.

432b

Socrates: But this, I suspect, is not the actual correctness of something qualitative, or of image in general. Rather, on the contrary, if the image is to be an image, it absolutely must not assign all the qualities of whatever it is imitating. You decide if this makes sense. Would there be two things – Cratylus, and an image of Cratylus – if some god were to imitate not only your complexion and form as painters do, but made all that is inside

it just as it is within you, assigned the same softness and bodily warmth, and imparted to all this the motion and soul and intelligence that you have, and in short, placed something else alongside you possessing all the qualities you possess? Would there then be Cratylus and his image, or would there be two Cratyluses?

432c

Cratylus: I think there would be two Cratyluses, Socrates.

Socrates: Now do you see, my friend, that we need to look for another correctness of image and of whatever we spoke of just now, and should not insist that if anything is omitted or added in, it is no longer an image? Or are you unaware of the extent to which images fall short of possessing the same properties as whatever they are images of?

432d

Cratylus: I am aware.

Socrates: Well, Cratylus, the consequences arising from names, for the things they name, would be absurd if they resembled them entirely in every respect. For everything would presumably become double, and it would not be possible to say which of them was the thing itself, and which was the name.

Cratylus: That's true.

Socrates: Then be courageous enough, my noble friend, to accept that a name can be well given or not well given, and do not insist that it must include all the letters in order to be exactly like whatever it names, but allow an inappropriate letter to be brought in. And if this is so for a letter, then let it be so for the name in a phrase, and if for a phrase, then accept that an inappropriate phrase may be brought into a sentence and that the thing is no less named and spoken of provided the impression of the thing the sentence is concerned with is included. This, if you recall, is what happens with the names of

the letters as Hermogenes and I explained earlier.

433a

Cratylus: Yes, I remember.

Socrates: Very well. Indeed, once this impression is included, even if everything appropriate is not present, the thing will still be described well when all are present, badly when few are present. Now, we should accept this, my friend, so that we don't get caught like people who roam the streets of Aegina late at night. Indeed, we too may seem, in truth, to have come to these matters later than we should, but the alternative is to search for another correctness of a name, and not accept that a name is an indication of the thing by means of syllables and letters. For if you make both of these assertions, you will be unable to be consistent with yourself.

433b

Cratylus: Well, Socrates, what you are saying sounds reasonable to me and I accept it.

Socrates: Well, since we are agreed on these matters, let's consider the following question. Do we maintain that a name should contain the appropriate letters in order to be well given?

Cratylus: Yes.

433c

Socrates: Are the appropriate letters those that are like the things that are named?

Cratylus: Certainly.

Socrates: So, those that are well given are given in this way. But if some name is not well given, it may still be composed mostly of appropriate letters that are like the things named, if it is indeed to be an image, but it may also contain something inappropriate because of which the name would be neither good, nor well made. Is this our position, or is it otherwise?

Cratylus: I don't think there is any point in arguing, Socrates. Yet I am still not satisfied with the claim that it is a name although it is not well given.

433d

Socrates: Are you satisfied that the name is an indication of the thing named?

Cratylus: I am.

Socrates: Don't you think it is right to say that some names are composed of prior names, while others are first?

Cratylus: I do.

Socrates: If the first ones are to become indications of things, do you know any better manner of them becoming indications besides making them, as much as possible, like the things they should indicate? Or do you prefer the manner suggested by Hermogenes, and many others too, whereby names are conventions and they indicate things to those who agreed the conventions having had prior knowledge of the things. They say that this convention constitutes the correctness of names and it makes no difference whether we adopt a convention based upon current usage or the opposite, and call what is now called small, large, and what is now called large, small. So which of the two manners do you prefer?

434a

Cratylus: To indicate whatever we are to indicate by means of likenesses, Socrates, is completely better in every way than proceeding at random.

Socrates: Very good. Now, if the name is to be like the thing, mustn't the letters from which the first names are composed necessarily be, by their nature, like the things? I am asking, using a previous example; if there were no naturally occurring pigments, similar to those from which the painted items which the painter's skill imitates are constituted, could anyone paint a

painting like any of the things that are? Or would that be impossible?

434b

Cratylus: Impossible.

Socrates: Now, similarly, could names ever be like anything at all, unless, in the first place, those elements from which the names are composed possessed some likeness to the things of which the names are imitations? And the names are composed of letters, are they not?

Cratylus: Yes.

Socrates: Well, at this stage, you should involve yourself in the discussion I had earlier with Hermogenes. So, do you think we are right in saying that the letter ‘r’ bears a resemblance to motion, moving and hardness? Or is this not right?

434c

Cratylus: I think it is right.

Socrates: And does the letter ‘l’ resemble smoothness, softness, and the other qualities we mentioned?

Cratylus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, you know that, speaking of the same thing (hardness), we say ‘sklērotēs’, while the Eritreans say ‘sklērotēr’?

Cratylus: Certainly.

Socrates: So, are both the ‘r’ and the ‘s’ like the same thing, and does the name ending in ‘r’ indicate the same thing to them, as the name ending in ‘s’ does to us? Or does the name fail as an indicator in one case or the other?

434d

Cratylus: No, it indicates the same thing to both of us.

Socrates: Is that because ‘r’ and ‘s’ happen to be alike, or because they are not?

Cratylus: Because they are alike.

Socrates: Are they alike in every respect?

Cratylus: Insofar as they equally indicate motion.

Socrates: What about the ‘l’ that is included in the name? Doesn’t this indicate the opposite of hardness?

Cratylus: Perhaps it has been included in error, Socrates, like the examples you gave to Hermogenes just now when you subtracted or added letters that were required. I think you were right to do so, and in this case perhaps an ‘r’ should be used rather than the ‘l’.

434e

Socrates: Very good. Well then, speaking as we are right now, don’t we understand one another when one of us says ‘sklēron’, and don’t you know what I am now saying?

Cratylus: I do, but because of custom, my friend.

Socrates: When referring to ‘custom’, do you think you are speaking of something distinct from convention? Or when you say ‘custom’, do you simply mean that when I utter this word I have hardness in mind, and you recognise that I have it in mind? Isn’t this what you mean?

435a

Cratylus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, if you recognise what I am uttering, doesn’t this constitute an indication for you from me?

Cratylus: Yes.

Socrates: And yet I am uttering what I have in mind, using that which is unlike, since you maintain that the ‘l’ is unlike hardness. But if this is the case, what else is this except a

convention you have made with yourself, whereby the correctness of names becomes convention for you? Since the like and unlike letters both act as an indication, don't these turn out to be a matter of custom and convention for you? But even if custom is not convention at all, it would still be incorrect to maintain that likeness rather than custom is the basis of indication, since custom, it seems, gives an indication using both like and unlike letters.

435b

Socrates: Now, Cratylus, since you agree with all this, for I take your silence as assent, it must be the case, I suppose, that when we speak what we have in mind, both convention and custom make some contribution towards indicating this. Indeed, best of men, would you like to turn your attention to number? Where will you get like names to apply to each one of the numbers unless you grant some authority to agreement on your part, and to convention in relation to the correctness of names? Now, I myself favour this notion that names be as much like the things they refer to as possible. But there may be truth in Hermogenes' claim that the actual attraction of likeness is fraught with difficulty, and for the correctness of names it may be necessary to have recourse to the lowly expedient of convention. Indeed, we would speak best if, as far as possible, we were to use words that are likenesses in all cases, or as many as we could, and this means using those that are appropriate, whereas with the opposite approach our speech would be degenerate. Now, answer one more question for me. What power do names possess for us, and what should we say they accomplish well?

435d

Cratylus: To instruct, Socrates, that's my opinion, and the simple fact is that whoever has knowledge of the names also has knowledge of the things they name.

Socrates: Yes, Cratylus, perhaps you mean that once someone knows what the name is like, and it is like the thing it names, he will then know the thing too since it happens to be like the name, and there is a single skill that is the same for all things that are like one another. And that, I believe, is why you say that whoever knows the names also knows the things named.

435e

Cratylus: Very true.

Socrates: Come on then, let's look at this. What would be this manner of instruction about things, the one you spoke of just now? And is there another one that is better than this, or is there no other besides this? What do you think?

436a

Cratylus: Just as you say, there is no other manner at all. This is the only way and this is the best way.

Socrates: And do you think that discovering things is the same as this, and that whoever discovers the names has also discovered the things of which they are the names? Or is this a method of instruction only, while enquiry and discovery require a different method?

Cratylus: Enquiry and discovery certainly involve the same method in every respect.

Socrates: Come on then, Cratylus, let's think about this. If someone who was enquiring into the things were to follow the names by considering what each name means, don't you think there is a significant danger of him being deceived?

436b

Cratylus: How so?

Socrates: Obviously, whoever first gave the names, gave names based on what he thought the things were like. Is this what we maintain?

Cratylus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, if this person was thinking incorrectly and gave the names based upon incorrect thinking, what do you believe would happen to those of us who follow him? Could we avoid being deceived?

Cratylus: But, Socrates, this is not the case. Rather, whoever gave the names must necessarily have had knowledge; otherwise, as I said some time ago, they would not be names at all. And there is considerable evidence that the name-giver did not miss the truth; otherwise all his names would never be so concordant. Did you yourself not reflect, as you spoke, that all the names came into being on the same basis and for the same purpose?

436c

Socrates: But that, my dear Cratylus, is no defence. For if the name-giver, having erred with the first name, forced the others thereafter into concord with this, and compelled them into concord with his own error, that would not be an unusual occurrence. This sometimes happens with geometrical diagrams where an initial, minor, unnoticed error occurs, and thereafter all the remaining additions are in agreement with one another. So everyone should give a great deal of deliberation and consideration to the beginning of an undertaking to see whether it has been established correctly or not. Once that has been adequately scrutinised, all else appears to follow from that. However, I would be surprised if names are actually in concord with one another. Indeed, let's examine our previous account once more where we maintained that the names indicated that the being of everything is moving, progressing and flowing. Don't you think that this is what they indicate?

437a

Cratylus: Very much so, and their indications are correct.

Socrates: Let's consider this by first selecting the word 'epistēmē' (knowledge). Note how ambiguous it is. Indeed, it seems to indicate that it impedes our soul's motion towards things rather than indicating that it is carried along with them. So, it is more correct to pronounce the beginning of the word as we do nowadays, and rather than inserting an 'e' and saying 'epeistēmē', we should insert an 'i' rather than an 'e'. The word 'bebaios' (definite) is some sort of imitation of 'basis' (foundation) or 'stasis' (rest) rather than motion. 'Historia' (investigation) presumably indicates that it prevents the flow (histēsi ton roun) and 'pistos' (faithful) certainly indicates 'preventing' (histan). The word 'mnēmē' (memory) presumably informs everyone that this is rest (monē) rather than motion in the soul. Or take 'hamartia' (error) or 'sumphora' (misfortune), if you go by the name, they will appear to be the same as 'sunesis' (understanding) and the same as 'epistēmē' (knowledge), and all the other names for things that are important to us. And indeed, 'amathia' (ignorance) and 'akolasia' (lack of restraint) also appear to be close to these in meaning, for 'amathia' (ignorance) appears to be 'the progression of one who proceeds with God' (tou hama theōi iontos poreia), while 'akolasia' (lack of restraint) certainly appears to be 'following along with things'. And accordingly, names that we believed to be associated with the worst things possible would appear to be very like those for the very best. And I think that anyone who took the trouble would discover many more examples from which we might come to rethink this matter, and conclude that whoever gave the names is indicating not that things are moving and progressing, but that they are at rest.

437d

Cratylus: But do you notice, Socrates, that most of them indicate motion?

Socrates: What of it, Cratylus? Shall we count the names as if they were votes, and will the correctness lie in this process? Whichever outcome appears to be indicated by most of the names is to be the true one. Is this so?

Cratylus: That is not reasonable.

438a

Socrates: Not at all, my friend. But let us leave these considerations and return to where we digressed. Indeed, a while ago, in the previous discussion, you said that whoever gave the names must necessarily have given them while being knowledgeable of the things to which he gave them. Are you still of this view or not?

Cratylus: Yes, I still am.

Socrates: And do you maintain that whoever gave the first names gave them while being knowledgeable?

Cratylus: Yes, knowledgeable.

438b

Socrates: But from what sort of names had he learned or discovered the things, since the first names had not yet been set down, and according to us it is impossible to learn about the things, or discover them in any other way, besides learning the names or discovering for ourselves what they are like?

Cratylus: I think you have a point there, Socrates.

Socrates: So, in what way should we maintain that they gave names knowledgeably or were convention-setters before a single name had been set down or they had known those names, if indeed it is not possible to learn about the things except from the names?

438c

Cratylus: I believe, Socrates, that the surest account of these matters is that some power, more than human, gave the first

names to things, and so they are necessarily correct.

Socrates: Do you believe then that whoever gave the names contradicted himself, even though he was a daimon or a god? Or do you think we were talking nonsense just now?

Cratylus: But one or the other of these groups are not names at all.

Socrates: Which of these two was incorrect, best of men, those leading in the direction of rest or in the direction of motion? For I presume, based on what was said just now, that the issue will not be decided by majority vote.

438d

Cratylus: Indeed not, Socrates, that would not be right.

Socrates: Now, since there is a conflict among the names, with some claiming that they are like the truth while others claim that they are it, how are we to decide between them and on what basis? Not, I presume, on the basis of other names, different from these, since there are none. It is obvious, rather, that something else apart from names must be sought which will reveal to us which of the two kinds of name is true, obviously by indicating the truth of things that are.

438e

Cratylus: Yes, I think so.

Socrates: So, Cratylus, if this is the case, it is possible without names to learn about things that are.

Cratylus: Apparently.

Socrates: Through what else then would you expect to learn about these? Wouldn't you do so through that which is both likely and most reasonable? Is there any alternative, then, than through one another, if they are somehow akin, and through themselves? For that which is different from those and of another kind would presumably indicate something different

and of another kind, but not those.

Cratylus: You appear to be speaking the truth.

439a

Socrates: Come on then, by Zeus, have we not agreed many times that the names that are well given are like whatever they are names of, and are images of the things?

Cratylus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, if the things really can be learned through the names and also through themselves, which of the two ways of learning would be better and more exact? Is it better to learn from the image, whether it is itself a good likeness, and also to learn the truth of that of which it is an image? Or is it better to learn from the truth, both the truth itself and whether the image of it has been properly fashioned?

439b

Cratylus: From the truth, necessarily so.

Socrates: To know the manner in which things are to be learned or discovered is perhaps too much for you and me. Let's be content to agree that it is not from names that things should be learned or investigated. It is much better to do so from themselves rather than from the names.

Cratylus: So it appears, Socrates.

439c

Socrates: Then let us consider how these various names that incline in the same direction may not deceive us. What if those who gave the names actually had in mind, as they did so, that all things are constantly moving and flowing? Now, it looks to me as if they did have this in mind. But what if this happens not to be the case, and these people themselves have, rather, fallen into a sort of whirlpool and are in the spin, dragging us along and making us fall in too? Indeed, my dear Cratylus, please consider something which I myself have often dreamed. Should

we, or should we not, maintain that there is such thing as beauty itself, and good itself, and so on for each of the things that are?

439d

Cratylus: I think we should, Socrates.

Socrates: Well, let us consider just that, not whether some particular face or something of this sort is beautiful, and whether all these seem to be in flux, but whether we should maintain, rather, that beauty itself is always the sort of thing that it is?

Cratylus: Necessarily.

Socrates: Now, if it is always slipping away, is it possible to say, firstly, that it is this, and secondly, that is something of this sort? Or even as we are speaking, is it necessarily becoming something else and slipping away and no longer being as it is?

Cratylus: Necessarily.

439e

Socrates: How could that which never remains as it is, be anything? For if it ever did remain as it is, it is obvious that at least for that period of time it would not change. And if it always remains as it is and is the same, how could this ever change or be in motion without departing from its own form?

Cratylus: It could not do so at all.

440a

Socrates: In that case, it could not be known by anyone either. For no sooner is it approached by someone who is to know it, than it becomes something else of a different kind, so that one would no longer know what it is like or what state it is in. And surely no knowledge whatsoever knows that which is not in any state at all.

Cratylus: Quite so.

Socrates: Indeed, if all things are changing and nothing remains the same, Cratylus, it is not even reasonable to say that there is knowledge. For if this thing itself, the knowledge, does not change from being knowledge, then knowledge would always remain and there would be knowledge. And if it is always changing, there would never be knowledge, and according to this argument there would be neither the knower nor the known. But if there is always the knower and there is always the known, and there is the beautiful and there is the good, and each one of the things that are, then it is not apparent to me that these things we are now speaking of bear any resemblance to flow or to motion. Now, it is not at all easy to investigate whether this is how matters stand or whether they accord with what the followers of Heraclitus say, and many others too. Nor would someone, fully possessed of intelligence, entrust the well-being of himself and his soul to names, and place his trust in these and in those who instituted them to be confident that he knows something – confident enough to allege, against himself and the things that are, that nothing at all is stable but all things are flowing like leaky jars, and to believe all things are in a condition much like people suffering from colds, and that dripping and flowing is the condition of everything. Perhaps this is how things are, Cratylus, or perhaps not. So you should conduct a brave and thorough enquiry and don't accept anything too easily, for you are still young and of the right age, so conduct your enquiry, and if you make a discovery, please share it with me too.

440d

Cratylus: I shall do as you say, but mark my words too, Socrates, I have not been neglectful of such enquiry. No, I have taken a lot of trouble to consider the matter, and things seem to me much more as Heraclitus says they are.

440e

Socrates: Yes, my friend, instruct me on some future occasion. Now, you should go into the countryside as you have arranged, and Hermogenes here will send you on your way.

Cratylus: So be it, Socrates, but you too should continue to think about these matters.

Critias

ΚΡΙΤΙΑΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

TIMAEUS *from Locris Epizephyrii, southern Italy*

CRITIAS *of Athens*

SOCRATES *of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus*

HERMOCRATES *of Syracuse*

scene: house of Critias, during the Panathenaea

106a

Timaeus: How glad I am, Socrates, to have come to the end of my protracted account. I feel relieved now, as if I were resting after a long journey. And I pray now to the god who has just been created in words, although created long ago in fact, to grant us the preservation of anything reasonable that we have said and to impose justice, as appropriate, if we have unwittingly gone out of tune on these subjects. And right justice means returning to harmony the person who has gone out of tune. Now, so that the remainder of our discourse about the creation of gods may be spoken aright, we pray that we may be given the most perfect and excellent medicine of all medicines, which is knowledge, and with this prayer I entrust the next discourse to Critias, as we agreed.

106c

Critias: Indeed, Timaeus, although I accept the task, I request some indulgence just as you did at the very outset, since I am about to speak on such major issues. I am now making the same request, but in view of what I am about to say, I deserve even more indulgence than yourself. And I am quite aware that the request I am about to make is most audacious and more blunt than needs be, but I must make it nevertheless.

107a

Critias: Who could reasonably even attempt to deny that everything you have said was good? But I must somehow endeavour to explain that the forthcoming exposition requires

still more indulgence because it is more difficult. Indeed, Timaeus, to sound competent whilst speaking to us humans about the gods is easier to achieve than when speaking about mortals to fellow mortals. For the inexperience and downright ignorance of the listeners about the subject in question makes it very easy for anyone who intends to speak about them to such an audience, and when it comes to the gods, we know where we stand. Follow me here so that I may explain what I mean more clearly. Indeed, anything that is said by any of us must presumably be of the nature of an imitation or representation. Let's look at the production of images of divine and human figures by painters, and how easy or difficult it is to convince the viewers that the imitation is good enough. We shall see firstly that in the case of landscapes, mountains, rivers, woods, the heaven in its entirety and whatever resides and moves there, we are satisfied if someone is able to produce an imitation that bears even a slight resemblance to any of these. Furthermore, since our knowledge of things of this sort is inexact, we do not scrutinise or challenge the paintings, but put up with an unclear and deceptive sketch in these cases.

107e

Critias: But whenever someone sets about producing a likeness of our own bodies, which we are so accustomed to observing, we quickly spot any deficiency and become harsh critics of anyone who does not present us with a full and complete likeness. Well, we need to observe that the same holds for accounts. In the case of the heavenly and divine, we are satisfied with accounts that are likely, even to a small extent, but when it comes to things mortal and human, we scrutinise the accounts with great precision. So, speaking at the moment, without any preparation, you will have to forgive us if we are unable to present an account that is fitting in every respect. For we need to bear in mind that to produce an acceptable likeness of things mortal is difficult rather than easy. Now, Socrates, I have said all

this to remind you of these facts and to request more indulgence, rather than less, for whatever I am about to say. If my request for this favour sounds fair, please be willing to grant it.

108b

Socrates: Why ever would we refuse your request, Critias? And let's grant the same favour again to our third speaker, Hermocrates. For it is obvious that in due course, when it is his turn to speak, he will make the same request as yourself, in which case, without being compelled to repeat the same opening request, let him rest assured that this indulgence is also available to him when it is his turn to speak so that he can provide a different preamble. And yet I forewarn you, dear Critias, of the disposition of your audience. The playwright who went before you was amazingly well received by them, and you will therefore require a great deal of indulgence if you are going to be a competent successor.

108c

Hermocrates: The same warning you gave to this man also applies to me, Socrates. But, of course, a faint-hearted man never set up a trophy, Critias, so you must embark upon your discourse courageously, calling upon Paeon and the Muses to present and sing the praises of your fellow citizens of old, who were such good people.

108d

Critias: My dear Hermocrates, having been assigned last place, with someone else going before you, you are still courageous, but you will soon find out what this process is really like. However, emboldened by your encouraging words, I must have faith and call upon the other gods besides those you mentioned, and especially upon Memory. For the most important of all our accounts rests more or less with this god. Indeed, if I can adequately recall and proclaim what was once spoken by the priests and preserved here by Solon, I am quite confident that I

shall be deemed by this audience to have done justice to my assigned task. So that is what I must now undertake without any further delay.

108e

Critias: First of all, then, let us recall that it is in total nine thousand years since war was declared between those dwelling outside the Pillars² of Heracles and all those who dwell within them. This I must now recount. One side was led, and the entire war was said to have been waged by this city of ours, while the other side was led by the kings of the island of Atlantis, which was, according to reports, an island, once larger than Libya and Asia combined. But nowadays, having been submerged during an earthquake, it acts as a barrier of mud obstructing those who wish to sail out into the open ocean from there.

109a

Critias: As for the various non-Greek peoples, and whatever Greek races there were at the time, the course of our narrative, as it unfolds, will reveal in each case the details of what happened to them everywhere. But in the case of the Athenians and the adversaries against whom they fought, it is necessary to begin by first recounting the power of each side and their political systems. And in speaking of these we must give precedence to our own people. Once upon a time, the gods, without any strife, allotted the entire earth. For it would not be right to suggest that gods are ignorant of what is proper to each of them, nor indeed that, having recognised what most belongs to other gods, they attempt to acquire this for themselves through strife. So, by lots, each was justly allotted his own, and they settled regions. And having settled them, they reared us, their possessions and livestock, except that they did not use physical force as shepherds do when driving their flocks to pasture with a staff. Instead, they led and steered the entire mortal creature in the way that is easiest to manage any living creature, guiding it from the stern, after their own mind, by the

rudder of persuasion.

109c

Critias: Now, other gods, having been allotted other regions, ruled over them, but Hephaestus and Athena, sharing a common nature as siblings born from the same father, sharing also the same pursuit of philosophy and craftsmanship, were allotted a single region. This was our region, a fitting and natural home for excellence and wisdom, and they produced good men, born from its soil, and they implanted in their minds the order of its political system. Although the names of these people have been preserved, their works have disappeared owing to the destructions of their successors and the long time period involved. For the people left behind on each occasion, as we said before, were illiterate mountain folk who had only heard the names of that region's rulers but knew little of their deeds. So, although they were happy to give these names to their own offspring, they were unaware of the excellent qualities and the laws of their predecessors, save for some obscure reports. They and their children lacked the necessities of life for many generations, and so they were preoccupied with what they lacked, and this became their topic of conversation and they had no interest in events of the distant past. For mythology and interest in antiquity come to cities along with leisure when they see that some people have already been furnished with the necessities of life, but not before then.

110a

Critias: That's why the names of the ancients have been preserved, but not their deeds. My evidence for what I say is the report of Solon that the Egyptian priests, describing the war that once took place, used many of these very names such as Cecrops, Erechtheus, Erichthoneus, Erysichthon, and most of the various names of the predecessors of Theseus that are recorded. The same applies to the names of the women too. And, indeed, the figure of the goddess as depicted, displayed as

she is in full battle armour, accords with the custom of the time whereby military activities were once common to men and women alike, an indication that in all cases where male and female creatures congregate together, it is always naturally possible for each kind to pursue its own proper excellence in common.

110c

Critias: Now, in those days, in this region, the various classes among our citizens were engaged in manufacturing and producing food from the earth. But the military class, having been set apart by divine men at the outset, dwelt separately, possessed of everything that was appropriate for their sustenance and training. None of them had any private property, and they asked their fellow citizens for no sustenance beyond the limits of sufficiency. Indeed, their entire lifestyle and customs were the same as those we described yesterday when speaking of those guardians whom we hypothesised. Furthermore, what is said about our land is persuasive and true: firstly that its boundaries at the time were defined by the Isthmus, and on the land side by the heights of Cithaeron and Parnes, and the boundaries went down with Oropus on the right, and Asopus constituted the sea boundary on the left. The soil in the region was more excellent than anywhere else, and that is why it was able to support a large army which was exempt from working the land. And there is strong evidence for its past excellence, since what's left nowadays is a match for any territory in productivity and fruitfulness and in the abundant pasture it affords to any livestock. But its produce in those days, as well as being excellent, came forth in vast quantities.

111b

Critias: Why should we believe this story and what is left of the land of old to confirm this account? The land as a whole is a long promontory, so to speak, extending from the general land mass far out into the ocean, and the seabed round about is of

great depth. Now, although there have been many enormous floods during the nine thousand years that have elapsed since that era, the earth that washed down from the heights during the ongoing deluges did not accumulate significantly, as happens in other places, because it constantly flowed down and vanished into the deep. What is left then, comparing that era with the present, resembles the skeleton of a diseased body. It is just like what happens on small islands where any fat, rich soil has flowed away, leaving behind only the bare frame of the territory. But during that era the land was pristine, our present mountains were lofty hills, and the stony plains of what we call Phelleus were covered in rich soil. The mountains contained lots of trees of which there is still evidence nowadays, for although some of our mountains now support only bees, it was not long ago that roof timbers were cut from the trees there for use in huge buildings, and the rafters still survive to this day. And there were also many cultivated trees providing fodder aplenty for livestock. What's more, the soil was made fruitful by the annual rains sent by Zeus, which were not wasted as happens nowadays by flowing into the sea from land that has been made bare. Rather, since the land had plenty of soil, it could indeed receive the water and store it in impervious clay ground. The water stored there was sent forth from the heights through hollows, providing plenty of flowing water for springs and rivers. The shrines that still remain where the springs once stood are an indication that what we are now saying about this region is true.

111d

Critias: Such was the natural condition of our region in general, and it was managed of course by true workers of the land, dedicated to this task alone, lovers of all things noble, with natural talents. They had access to the very best land with plenty of water, governed by seasons that were blended to perfection. The arrangement of the city at the time was as

follows. Firstly, the Acropolis at that time was not as it is nowadays, washed bare of its soil following a single night of extreme deluge when an earthquake occurred along with the third enormous flood prior to the destruction of the age of Deucalion⁴. But before this, in another era, it was vast, extending from the Eridanos to the Ilisos river, encompassing the Pnyx, with the hill of Lycabettos as a boundary opposite the Pnyx. The entire was covered in earth, and it was more or less flat on top. Outside, under the actual slopes, it was settled by craftsmen and those farmers who worked the land nearby. On the top, the military class dwelt just by themselves around the temple of Athena and Hephaestus, surrounded by a single wall, like the garden of a single household. On the north side, they lived in communal dwellings and provided shared dining halls for the winter, with everything appropriate to their communal political system being available to them in terms of buildings and temples, but without any silver or gold, for none of them had any use for these. Pursuing a middle ground between extravagance and meanness, they built moderate dwellings in which they and their children's children grew old, bequeathing them always to others like themselves. In summer they naturally vacated their enclosed gardens, and their gymnasias and dining halls, and used the southern parts for these purposes. There was a single spring, on the site of the present Acropolis, which has been blocked by the earthquakes, so that nowadays only trickles of water remain in the vicinity, whereas it once provided a plentiful flow of water for everyone at just the right temperature throughout winter and summer.

112d

Critias: This is how their lives were arranged as guardians of their own citizens and leaders of the other Greek peoples, their willing subjects. They kept careful watch that the number of men and women capable of military service at any stage was always more or less the same at about twenty thousand. Now

these Athenians, being themselves people of this sort, were renowned above all peoples of that age, justly managing their own region and Greece generally in such a consistent manner, famous throughout all of Europe and Asia for their physical beauty and the overall excellence of their souls. As for their adversaries, the sort of people they were and their origins, if my memory of what we heard as children does not desert me, I shall now bring their stories centre stage to share with you, my friends.

113a

Critias: But before I begin my account, I owe you a brief explanation in case you are surprised to hear of so many non-Greeks with Greek names. You shall now discover the reason for this. Solon, intending to make use of the Egyptian account in his own poem, found out, on investigating the significance of the names, that those Egyptians who had written them down initially had translated them into their own language. So he himself, having recovered the sense of each name, put them back once more into our language and wrote them down. And these writings were in the possession of my grandfather and are in my own possession now. Indeed, I studied them carefully as a child. So do not be surprised if you hear names of this sort, belonging to our region; you have the explanation.

113c

Critias: Well then, the story, a long one, began somewhat as follows. As was said previously about the allotments of the gods, they portioned the land into lots, some larger some smaller, and instituted sacred places and sacrifices for themselves. And so, Poseidon, being allotted the island of Atlantis⁵, settled his own offspring, begotten of a mortal woman there, in a region of the island described as follows. By the sea, towards the centre of the entire region, there was a plain said to be of sublime excellence, and fertile too. Near the plain, towards the centre, at a distance

of some fifty stades, there was a mountain that was low throughout. There was an inhabitant of that mountain, one of the men of that place born originally from its soil. His name was Evenor and he lived with his wife, Leucippe, and they had an only daughter, Cleito. When the girl had reached marriageable age, the father and mother both died. Poseidon was smitten with desire for the girl and made her his consort. He secured the hill on which she dwelt, fortifying it by making alternating circles of earth and sea, some smaller, some larger, enclosing each other, two of earth, three of seawater, like round wheels in the middle of the island, equidistant from one another on all sides so that they were impassable for people because there were, as yet, no ships and no seafaring. He brought order to the middle part of the island, an easy task for a god, providing two sources of spring water from beneath the ground, one warm, the other overflowing with cool water, and he sent forth from the earth abundant and plentiful food.

114a

Critias: Having begotten and reared five pairs of twin male children, he divided the entire island of Atlantis into ten parts, and assigned the mother's homestead to the eldest of the firstborn twins, including the surrounding portion of land which was the biggest and the best. He installed this son as king over his brothers and appointed the others as rulers giving them dominion over large numbers of people and an extensive territory. He gave names to them all, naming the eldest, the king, after the whole island and the ocean too, which is called the Atlantic because the first-ever person to exercise kingship there was named Atlas. His other twin was granted the extremity of the island towards the Pillars of Heracles, as far as the region now called Gadeira. The place was named after the son whose Greek name was Eumelos, although locally it was Gadeirus in his own region which is named after him. The second pair of twins were called Ampheres and Euaimon. The

eldest of the third pair was called Mneseus, while the other twin was called Autochton. The eldest of the fourth pair was called Elasippus, while the other was called Mestor. The eldest of the fifth pair was called Azaes, while the youngest was called Diaprepes. All these brothers, themselves and their descendants, dwelt there for many generations, ruling over numerous other islands of that ocean, and, indeed, as was said previously, governing all the peoples here within the Pillars of Heracles as far as Egypt and Tuscany.

114d

Critias: From Atlas sprang an extensive and revered people whose king, the eldest son, always passed his title on to the eldest of his offspring, thus preserving the kingship over many generations. They acquired enormous wealth such as no line of kings had amassed before or will easily attain in future. They were provided with all the provisions they needed in the city and in the rest of the country. For although a great deal came to them from outside because of their extensive rulership, the island itself furnished most of the provisions of life. Firstly, it yielded whatever solid or fusible materials are extracted or mined from the ground, including a substance that now exists in name only, but was then more than a mere name. This was orichalc, mined in various locations throughout the island, more valuable at the time than anything else except gold. The island also brought forth an abundance of wood for carpenters to work on, and it was well able to sustain animals too, both tame and wild. And, indeed, there was a plentiful population of elephants, for there was enough pasture available for all sorts of creatures, including those who dwelt in marshes, lakes, rivers, or indeed in mountains or on plains, and enough in like manner for this enormous animal, by nature the most voracious creature of all. As well as all this, the island brought forth and easily sustained whatever fragrant products the earth supports nowadays from roots, herbs, trees or juices that ooze from

flowers or fruits. There was also the cultivated fruit, the dry sort that is our sustenance, and those products that we use as our source of food, consisting in general of what we call pulses, and whatever grows on trees, providing us with drink, with solid food and oils, and tree-borne fruit that is difficult to store, acting as a source of pleasure and delectation which we offer to the fatigued to relieve their satiety. All these were brought forth then in limitless abundance and wondrous beauty by this sacred island beneath the sun. So, being in possession of all these products of the earth, they set about organising and building their temples, royal dwellings, harbours and dockyards, and the rest of their territory, based on the following plan.

115a

Critias: First, they bridged the rings of seawater that surrounded the ancient mother city, creating a way out of and into their palace. They immediately built the palace, at the very outset, in the original dwelling place of the god and his offspring, passing it on from one generation to the next, each adding to its adornments, each doing their best to continually improve upon the work of their predecessor, until they turned the residence into a marvel to behold for the majesty and beauty it displayed. In fact, they dug a canal running from the sea to the outermost circle, three plethra wide, one hundred feet deep and fifty stades long. In this way they created a passage from the sea into the outer circle by opening up an entrance big enough for the largest ships to sail into. And what's more, at the bridges they made openings in the circles of earth which were separating the circles of seawater, openings wide enough for a single trireme to sail through, and they covered these from above so that the ships travelled underground. For the banks of the earthen circles were high enough above sea level to allow this.

115d

Critias: Now, the largest circle, the one that opened directly to the sea, was three stades wide, while the next circle, the earthen one, was the same width as that one. Of the second pair, the circle of water was two stades wide, while the circle of dry land was again equal in width to the previous circle of water. The circle running round the central island itself was one stade wide, while that island on which the palace stood had a diameter of five stades. This island and the circles and the bridge which was one plethron wide, they enclosed roundabout on every side with a stone wall, erecting towers and gates upon the bridges on either side at the sea crossings. They quarried the stone, some of which was white, some black, some red, from beneath the central island, all over, and from beneath the inner and outer circles. And by quarrying the stone, they simultaneously hollowed out a pair of internal docks which they covered over with native rock. Some of their buildings were simple, while in others they combined stone of various colours to amuse themselves, thus making them naturally pleasing to the eye. They covered the entire wall surrounding the outer circle with brass all around, as if they were painting it, while they covered the wall of the inner circle with a coat of tin, and the wall surrounding the acropolis itself with orichalc, which gave it a fiery gleam.

116c

Critias: The palace within the acropolis was designed as follows. In the centre, on the very spot, surrounded by a wall of gold, was a sacred shrine on untrodden ground, dedicated to Cleito and Poseidon. This stood in the place where their family of ten kings was initially begotten and born. To this very place, every year, the first fruits from all ten regions were brought as an offering to each of the kings. There was also a temple to Poseidon himself, one stade in length, three plethra wide, with its height duly proportioned to these dimensions, while its appearance was somehow foreign. The entire exterior of the

temple was overlaid with silver, except for the acroteria, which were covered with gold. On the inside the ceiling was all ivory, decorated with gold and silver and orichalc, while everything else, including the walls, columns and floor, was covered with orichalc. Within, they erected golden statues depicting the god standing upon a chariot, controlling a team of six winged horses, he himself being so tall that his head touched the roof. Encircling this were statues of a hundred Nereids riding upon dolphins, for people at the time believed that there were this many Nereids. Inside, there were also many other statues erected by private individuals. Outside, around the temple, stood golden images of the wives of the ten kings and their descendants, and various other large statues of the kings and of private persons from the city itself, or from foreign places over which they ruled. Their size and workmanship were in harmony with the overall design, and the palace was similarly well suited to the sheer scale of their rulership and the glory of the shrine.

117a

Critias: They made use of both springs, the hot one and a cold one, each providing plenty of water, wondrously pleasant and excellent by nature. And they built dwellings round about and planted suitable trees. There were pools in the area, some cold and in the open air, others warm and covered over for use as baths in winter. There were separate pools for the kings, for private citizens and for women, and others for horses and the various beasts of burden, with appropriate facilities provided in each case. The overflow was channeled to the grove of Poseidon, which, because of its excellent soil, contained a variety⁷ of lofty trees of exceptional beauty. They also channelled the water to the outer circles through pipes running along the bridges. There they had constructed many shrines to various gods, and gardens and gymnasia aplenty, some for men, some especially for horses, on each of the two circular islands. And, in particular, in the middle of the larger island there was a

racetrack reserved for horses, which was one stade wide and whose length was the circuit of the entire island. This space was set aside for equestrian competitions. And around the track on either side were guard houses for most of the bodyguards, although the more trustworthy among them were posted on the smaller circle, closer to the acropolis, while the most eminently trustworthy of all were allowed to reside within the acropolis, close to the kings themselves. The dockyards were full of triremes and all their necessary equipment, and everything was at the ready.

117d

Critias: That is how the residence of the kings was arranged. But beyond the three harbours, outside them, was a circular wall beginning from the sea, everywhere fifty stades distant from the largest circle and its harbours, circling back to the same place where the mouth of the canal opened to the sea. The wall was densely populated with large numbers of houses, while the canal and the largest harbour was full of ships and traders arriving from all quarters, so many that they produced a fantastic commotion and din, day and night.

117e

Critias: Well, I have now given a fairly good report of the city and the environs of the ancient dwelling place as recounted then. I should now attempt to recall the nature and arrangement of the rest of the region. Firstly, the place was said to be elevated, with sheer cliffs rising out of the sea, while the entire area surrounding the city was a plain enclosing the city, itself enclosed by a ring of mountains stretching as far as the sea. The plain was level and smooth, elongated throughout, three thousand stades in one direction and two thousand stades inland from the sea at its centre. This particular section of the entire island was south-facing and was sheltered from the north winds.

118b

Critias: The mountains around the city were lauded at the time for their number, size and beauty, surpassing anything we have nowadays. In the mountains there were many prosperous villages with local populations, and rivers, lakes and meadows that could adequately support all the domesticated and wild animals, and an abundant variety of timber, more than enough for each and every function. Now, the plain, by nature, and because it had been cultivated by many kings over many years, had the following characteristics. It was originally four-sided, oblong, and for the most part a rectangle, but whatever it lacked in this respect they corrected by digging a trench around it. As for the depth, width and length of the trench, it is incredible to relate how any work of human hands could be so vast when compared with our usual endeavours, but I must tell you what I heard in any case. It was excavated to a depth of one plethron and it was everywhere one stade wide, while its length, running around the entire plain, was a thousand stades. It received the waters that flowed down from the mountains as it encircled the plain, and arriving at the city from both directions, it was set on its course out to the sea. Further inland from the city, one-hundred-foot-wide straight channels were cut across the plain, emptying again into the trench on the seaward side. Each of the channels stood a hundred stades apart from the other. These were used to transport wood from the mountains down to the city, and for conveying the rest of the seasonal produce in ships by cutting cross-channels sideways, connecting the channels to one another and to the city. They took two crops from the land each year, relying upon the rains sent by Zeus in the winter, and in summer upon whatever the earth produced when they irrigated it from the channels.

119a

Critias: Out of the total number of men on the plain fit to bear arms, it was decreed that each lot was to provide one leader. The size of a lot was ten stades by ten, and the total number of

lots was sixty thousand. From the mountains and the region in general, there was, according to reports, an enormous number of people, all assigned on the basis of their localities and villages, to these lots and their leaders. Each leader was directed, for military purposes, to provide one-sixth portion of a war chariot for a thousand chariots, two horses with riders, a team of two horses without a chariot-board, including a fighter with a light shield and a driver for the pair of horses who was to remain with them, two hoplites and two archers and slingers, three light-armed stone-throwers and the same number of javelin-throwers, and four sailors for the ships whose full fleet numbered twelve hundred. So this is how the military equipment of the royal city was organised. The various arrangements of the other nine cities would take too long to recount.

119b

Critias: The distribution of positions of authority and of honour was, from the very beginning, as follows. Each one of the ten kings had authority over the people and most of the laws in his own region and his own city, punishing and executing whomsoever he wished. Their authority over one another and their communal affairs were subject to the edicts of Poseidon, which the law transmitted to them, as did the inscriptions of the first kings written on a pillar of orichalc placed on the central island in the sanctuary of Poseidon. There they gathered every fifth year or every sixth year, alternately, thus showing equal respect for the odd and the even portion. When they met they deliberated about their communal affairs, enquired into any transgressions by any of them, and passed judgement. When they were about to deliver their judgement, they first gave pledges to one another as follows. There were bulls roaming free in the sanctuary of Poseidon. The ten kings, being present on their own, prayed that the god would select a sacrificial victim that was pleasing to himself. They then hunted

with ropes and with wooden weapons containing no iron, and whatever bull they captured they brought to the pillar and cut its throat over the top of the pillar, drenching the inscription with blood.

120a

Critias: Now, inscribed on the pillar, in addition to the laws, was an oath calling down mighty curses upon those who disobeyed. So when they had sacrificed in accordance with their own laws, they would dedicate all parts of the bull, and having blended a mixing bowl of wine, they threw in a clot of blood on behalf of each of them, and then having first cleansed the pillar, they poured the rest of the blood into the sacrificial fire. After this, they drew off some wine into golden vessels and made a libation over the fire, swearing an oath to judge in accordance with the laws inscribed upon the pillar, to punish anyone who had previously been a transgressor, and, furthermore, never intentionally to transgress any of the ordinances nor to exercise or submit to authority, save in accordance with the laws of their father. Having sworn all this on his own behalf and on behalf of their succeeding generations, each of them drank and offered up their vessel in the sanctuary of the god. Then, having spent their time engaging in the banquet and any necessary transactions, they all, once darkness had fallen, robed themselves in the most beautiful purple raiment, sat upon the ground by the embers of the ritual fire, and by night, with all fires in the sanctuary extinguished, they delivered and submitted themselves to judgement, if any of them accused the other of any transgression. When the light returned, they inscribed these on a tablet of gold and dedicated this along with their robes as a memorial.

120d

Critias: Now, although there were many other particular laws concerning the rights of the several kings, the most important were that they should never bear arms against one another;

that they would all provide assistance if anyone tried to overthrow the royal family in any city; that in accordance with tradition they would deliberate together on military issues and general concerns, granting leadership to the house of Atlas; and that the king was to have no authority to put a kinsman to death without the agreement of half of the ten. Such was the nature and the extent of the power in those regions at the time. The god, however, arrayed this power and set it against our region, and the motive for this was said to be as follows.

120e

Critias: For many generations, as long as the nature of the god held sway in them, they were obedient to the laws and lovingly disposed towards their kindred god. For their thoughts were true and universal, dealing with one another and life's chance events with wisdom and humility. So they despised everything apart from excellence, thought little of their possessions, and easily bore their heap of gold and other acquisitions as if it were a light burden. They were not drunk on luxury, nor did they flounder because their wealth robbed them of self-control. Being sober-minded, they clearly saw that through communal love accompanied by excellence, all these material goods increase, but the more seriously we take them and the more we honour them, the more do they diminish, while excellence perishes along with them. So, based upon such reasoning as this, and with the persistence of their divine nature, all the wealth we previously described increased. But once the divine portion within them became faded by being mixed again and again with much mortality, their human character became dominant, they were unable to bear their possessions, their behaviour deteriorated, and to those with eyes to see they were an obvious disgrace for they had destroyed their most sublime and precious of possessions. But to those who were unable to see what, in truth, constitutes a happy life, these people seemed, at this stage, to represent the very pinnacle of

goodness and happiness, despite being infected with unjust ambition and power.

121b

Critias: Zeus, god of gods, who exercises his kingship through laws, since he was able to view such matters with clarity, recognised the wretched plight of this fair race, and decided that they should meet with justice to chasten them and make them more orderly. So he gathered all the gods together in their most hallowed dwelling-place, situated at the very centre of the universe with a clear view of the entire realm of becoming, and, having assembled them, he said...

NOTES

1. A healing god associated with Apollo.
2. The 'Pillars of Heracles' is a reference to the Straits of Gibraltar.
3. These are the names of legendary Greek kings. The first three were kings of Attica, the wider region that includes Athens; the fourth was a king of Thessaly.
4. Deucalion was a mythical figure associated with a cataclysmic flood, which he and his wife Pyrrha survived.
5. The account of Atlantis mentions three units of measure: the foot, the plethron (100 feet), and the stade (600 feet).
6. Modern-day Cádiz in southern Spain.
7. The name orichalc, which literally means 'mountain copper', refers to a precious metal of unknown variety.
8. Acroteria were architectural ornaments that were situated at the apex or corners of pediments.
9. Nereids were sea nymphs who were often depicted riding various real and imagined sea creatures.

Crito

ΚΡΙΤΩΝ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

CRITO a friend and contemporary of Socrates

scene: a prison in or near the Athenian Agora

43a

Socrates: Why have you arrived at this hour, Crito? Isn't it still early?

Crito: It certainly is.

Socrates: What time is it, then?

Crito: Just before dawn.

Socrates: I am surprised the prison guard was willing to answer the door for you.

Crito: He knows me well at this stage, Socrates, because I visit the place so often and, what's more, I have done him a favour.

Socrates: Did you arrive just now, or some time ago?

Crito: Quite some time ago.

43b

Socrates: Then why didn't you wake me immediately instead of sitting there in silence?

Crito: No, by Zeus, I wouldn't do that. I only wish I were not so sleepless and so troubled myself, but I am also amazed at you when I notice how sweetly you sleep, and I deliberately refrained from waking you so that you might pass the time as pleasantly as possible. And on many previous occasions, all through your life, I have noted your happy disposition, especially now that I see how easily and calmly you are bearing this present misfortune.

Socrates: Actually, Crito, it would be most odd, at my age, to be troubled because I now had to die.

43c

Crito: But, Socrates, other men of your age have been overtaken by similar misfortunes, yet their age does not free them from being troubled over their predicament.

Socrates: That's true. But why have you come so early?

Crito: Socrates, I am the bearer of painful news. Not painful for you, apparently, but for me and all your associates it is both painful and grievous, and I think I am the one who bears it most grievously of all.

43d

Socrates: What news is this? Has the ship arrived from Delos¹, the one whose arrival means that I must die?

Crito: Well, it has not actually arrived but I think it will be here today, based on reports from some people who have come from Sounion² and who left the ship there. So it is clear from these reports that it will be here today, and so, Socrates, tomorrow your life must come to an end.

Socrates: Well, Crito, may it be for the best. If this pleases the gods, so be it. However, I do not think it will be here today.

44a

Crito: What is your evidence for that?

44b

Socrates: I'll tell you. Presumably I am to die the day after the ship arrives.

Crito: That is what the authorities say, in any case.

Socrates: Well, I do not think it will be here today, but tomorrow. My evidence is a dream I had a little earlier, during the night, perhaps when you decided not to wake me.

Crito: What was the dream?

Socrates: "Socrates, on the third day thou shalt reach fertile Phthia³." – I thought that a noble and beautiful woman wearing

a white robe approached me, called out and said these words.

Crito: What a strange dream, Socrates.

Socrates: Well now, Crito, it seems clear enough to me anyway.

Crito: It seems all too clear, but dearest Socrates, even at this stage heed me and save yourself. For if you die it is not just a single misfortune for me. No, quite apart from being deprived of a friend, the like of whom I shall never find again, many people who do not know you and me at all well will think that I did not care enough to spend some money to save you. And what reputation could be more disgraceful than this, a reputation for setting higher value on money than on friends? For most people will not believe that you yourself were unwilling to leave this place, although we were willing to help.

44c

Socrates: But bless you, Crito, why does popular opinion concern us so much? The best people, whose opinions are more worthy of consideration, will believe that we acted exactly as we should have acted.

Crito: But Socrates, surely you can see that it is indeed necessary to care about popular opinion? The very situation we are now in demonstrates that if someone is discredited in their eyes, the multitude can do harm, not only on the smallest of scales, but well-nigh the greatest harm of all.

Socrates: I really wish the multitude were able to do the greatest harm, Crito, so that they might also be able to do the greatest good, and all would be well. As it is, they are not able to do either, for they cannot make someone either wise or foolish, and they do whatever occurs to them.

44d

Crito: Let's accept all that, Socrates. But just tell me, if you escape from here, are you concerned for me and for your other associates in case the informers make trouble for us and we

have to forfeit all our property or incur a large fine or suffer some worse fate at their hands? For if you are afraid of any such outcome, bid it farewell, for it is only right that we run these risks to save you, and even greater risks if necessary. So, heed me and just do as I say.

Socrates: Yes, I am concerned about this, Crito, and much else besides.

44e

Crito: Then don't be afraid. In fact, the people who can save you and get you out of here are not looking for a lot of money. Besides, you see, don't you, that these informers are so easily bought that we won't need to spend much money on them either? My own funds are at your disposal, and I believe they are adequate. What's more, if you are concerned about me and don't believe you should spend my money, there are friends here from abroad willing to spend theirs. One of them, Simmias⁴ the Theban, has brought sufficient money for this very purpose. Cebes too is ready, and very many others.

45a

Crito: So, as I say, don't give up on saving yourself for fear of these issues, nor should what you said in court present a difficulty for you, that you would not know what to do with yourself if you went into exile. For there are lots of places where they will welcome you, wherever you go. And if you want to go to Thessaly⁵, I have friends there who will make much of you and provide you with protection so that you are not bothered by any of the Thessalians.

45d

Crito: What's more, Socrates, I don't even think that what you are attempting is right, betraying yourself when you could save yourself, determined to bring upon yourself the sort of thing your enemies would be keen on in their determination to destroy you. As well as this, I also think you are betraying your

own sons by going off and abandoning them when you could rear them and educate them. For all you care, they will meet whatever fate they meet, and they will quite likely meet the sort of fate that usually befalls orphans in these situations. In fact, one should either not beget children at all or else face the difficulties of rearing and educating them. And I think you are choosing the easy way out when you should choose whatever a good and courageous man would choose, especially when you spend your entire life speaking of concern for excellence. So, I am ashamed both on your behalf and on behalf of ourselves, your associates, lest this entire situation in which you are involved may seem to have developed because of some cowardice on our part: the fact that the action went to court when it was possible that it not go to court, how the trial of the action itself unfolded, and, to cap it all, as the most absurd aspect of the matter, people will think that an opportunity escaped us due to our own baseness and cowardice, since we did not save you, nor did you save yourself, when we were well able to do so if we were of any use at all. So beware, Socrates, in case these matters bring not just evil upon yourself and others, but disgrace too. So make your decision. No, the time for making decisions is past, just decide. There is only one decision. Yes, everything must happen this very night, and if we delay any longer it won't be possible. So heed me, Socrates, you must do exactly as I say.

46b

Socrates: Crito, my friend, your eagerness would be very worthy if it had right on its side, but, if not, then the greater the eagerness, the greater the problem. Now, we need to consider whether we should adopt this course of action or not, as I am, now and always, the sort of person who heeds nothing else but the reasoning that on reflection appears best to me. So I cannot now cast aside the reasoned arguments I have stated before because of what has just happened to me. No, they seem much

the same, and I honour and respect the same principles as before. And if we have no better arguments to offer at the moment, then rest assured, I shall not go along with your plan, not even if the power of the populace scares us, like children, to an even greater extent than now by threatening either imprisonment, execution or confiscation of property.

46d

Socrates: So, how may we consider the issues in the most balanced way? What if we first take up the argument you proposed in relation to opinions? Were we right, or were we not, when we said on many occasions that we should pay attention to some opinions but not to others? Or were we right before I was condemned to death, but it has now become quite evident that this was said idly, for the sake of argument, and was, in truth, childish nonsense? And I am eager to consider, along with you, Crito, whether the argument appears in a different light since this has happened to me, or remains the same, whether we should bid it farewell or heed it. It used often to be said, I believe, by those of us who thought they had a point, that, as I have just said, some opinions that people arrive at should be valued highly, others not. By the gods, Crito, don't you think this is a fair statement? For you, humanly speaking, are not expected to die tomorrow, and the present situation should not unhinge you, so think about this. Don't you think it is enough to say that we should not respect all the opinions of mankind, but some only and not others, and not the opinions of all people, but of some people and not others? What do you say? Is it right to say this?

47a

Crito: It is right.

47b

Socrates: Shouldn't we respect the worthy opinions and not the bad ones?

Crito: Yes.

Socrates: Aren't the worthy ones the opinions of the wise, and the bad ones the opinions of the foolish?

Crito: They must be.

47c

Socrates: Come on then. What have we generally said about such matters? When a man is in training and is working at it, does he pay attention to the praise and censure and the opinions of anyone at all, or to one person alone, the person who happens to be a physician or a trainer?

Crito: To one person alone.

Socrates: Therefore, he should fear the censure and delight in the praise of that one person, and not those of the majority.

Crito: Obviously.

Socrates: So, he should go about it as follows: exercise, and even eat and drink, in the way that that one person, his trainer, the knowledgeable person, thinks he should, rather than all the others.

47d

Crito: This is so.

Socrates: So be it. But if he doesn't heed that one person, and disrespects his opinion and his praise, and respects those of the majority who are not at all knowledgeable, won't he suffer harm?

Crito: Inevitably.

Socrates: What is this harm, to what is it directed, and what part of the heedless person does it affect?

Crito: Obviously it affects his body, since it ruins it.

Socrates: That's right. And without going through them all, Crito, doesn't the same issue arise in other cases too, and especially when it comes to justice and injustice, disgrace and nobility, good and bad, with which our deliberations are now concerned? Should we follow the opinion of the majority and fear it, or the opinion of one person, someone who is knowledgeable, and feel more shame and fear before him than before all the others put together? And if we do not follow him, shan't we corrupt and maim that which we agreed is made better by justice and ruined by injustice? Or is this nothing?

47e

Crito: I agree with you, Socrates.

Socrates: Come on then. If by paying no heed to the opinion of knowledgeable people we ruin that which is improved by health and corrupted by disease, would our life be worth living when this had been corrupted? And this, presumably, is the body, isn't it?

Crito: Yes.

Socrates: So, for us, is life worth living with a degenerate and corrupted body?

Crito: Not at all.

Socrates: Then, is our life worth living when that which injustice maims and justice improves has been corrupted? Or do we believe that the part of us, whatever it is, that is associated with injustice and justice to be less honourable than the body?

48a

Crito: Not at all.

Socrates: Is it more honourable?

Crito: Much more.

Socrates: So, best of men, we should not give any thought to what most people will say of us. No, we should heed what the person who knows justice and injustice says, that one person, and truth itself. So your first proposal was not right when you proposed that we should take account of popular opinion concerning what is just, noble and good, and their opposites. Yet someone might still say, “Yes, but the multitude is able to put us to death!”

48b

Crito: Of course someone would say that, Socrates.

Socrates: What you say is true. But, my friend, the argument we have just gone through still seems much the same to me as it did previously. And we should also consider further whether this principle of ours still stands, that we should not attach importance to living, but to living well.

Crito: It still stands.

Socrates: And to live well is to live nobly and justly. Does this stand or not?

Crito: It stands.

48c

Socrates: In that case, based upon what has been agreed, we should consider whether I am justified in trying to get out of here without permission from the Athenians or not. And if it turns out to be justified, we should make the attempt, and if not, we should let it be. But the considerations you introduce, concerning financial expenditure, opinion, and the upbringing of my children, these, I truly suspect, Crito, are the notions of those who would readily put a man to death and then bring him back to life again if they could, notions devoid of reason, the notions of the multitude. But we, since the argument so convinces us, should consider nothing except what we said just now: whether we shall be acting justly in bestowing money and

favours upon the people who will get me out of here, and in escaping and aiding the escape ourselves. Or shall we, in truth, be acting unjustly in doing all this? And if it is evident that we shall be acting unjustly, there is no need to consider whether we should quietly stand our ground and face death, or suffer any other fate whatsoever. We should only consider the injustice of the act.

48d

Crito: What you are saying is all very well, Socrates, but you still need to decide what we should do.

48e

Socrates: Let's consider this together, good man, and if you are able to contradict what I am saying in any way, do so, and I shall heed you. Otherwise, at this stage, blessed man, please stop presenting the same argument to me over and over – that I need to get out of here without the permission of the Athenians – for it is very important to me that I do all this with your approval and not against your will. Now look at the principle of the enquiry, and whether it is stated adequately, and try to answer the questions you are asked, as you think best.

49a

Crito: Well, I'll try.

Socrates: Are we saying that injustice should not be done intentionally in any way, or should injustice be done in one way but not in another? Or is unjust action not at all good or noble, as we have agreed so often on previous occasions? Or has everything we previously agreed been cast aside in these past few days, and have we, at our age, Crito, despite conversing earnestly with one another for so long, overlooked the fact that we are no better than children? Or is it very much the case, as we said then, that whether the multitude say so or not, and whether we must suffer more grievous afflictions, or even milder ones, doing injustice is evil in any case, and disgraceful

in every way, for the one who acts unjustly? Do we accept this or not?

49b

Crito: We do.

Socrates: So we should never act unjustly?

Crito: Of course not.

49c

Socrates: Nor since we should never act unjustly, should we return an injustice if we are treated unjustly, as most people think?

Crito: Apparently not.

Socrates: What about this, Crito, should we do harm or not?

Crito: Of course we shouldn't, Socrates.

Socrates: And if we suffer harm, is it just to do harm in return, as most people assert, or is it not just?

Crito: Not at all.

Socrates: Presumably because doing harm to people is no different from acting unjustly.

Crito: That's true.

49d

Socrates: So we should neither return an injustice nor do harm to any man, regardless of what we suffer at his hands. And take care, Crito, in accepting this, in case you agree to something that goes against your own opinion, since I know that these opinions are held, and will be held, by a few. Now, there is no common counsel between those who hold this view and those who do not, and they must of necessity despise one another when they see one another's decisions. So you too should consider, very carefully, whether you share this view and agree with it, and we should begin our deliberations from this. Is it

never right to do injustice or to return an injustice, or to defend yourself from suffering harm by doing harm in return? Or do you dissent, and do you not share this principle? I have long held this view, and I still do so now, but if you hold a different one speak and explain it. However, if you stand by what we agreed earlier, hear what follows.

49e

Crito: Well, I stand by it and I agree with you, so speak on.

Socrates: Then, the next thing I say, or rather ask, is should a person do whatever he agrees with someone to do, provided it is just, or should he cheat him?

Crito: He should do it.

50a

Socrates: Then look at the matter based on these principles. In leaving this place without having convinced the city, are we doing harm, even to those we should harm least of all? Or are we not doing harm, and are we abiding by our agreements since they are just?

Crito: I can't answer your question, Socrates, because I do not understand it.

Socrates: Well, consider this. Suppose I was about to run away, or call it what you will, and the laws of the city and the community were to arrive, stand before us, and ask: "Tell me, Socrates, what are you intending to do? Do you have anything else in mind, for your part, than to destroy us, the laws, and the entire city too, by your plan of action? Or do you think any city can exist and not be overthrown when its just enactments have no force and are rendered ineffective by private citizens, and set at naught?" What answer would we give, Crito, to these questions and others like them? Someone, especially a rhetorician, might have a lot to say about the subversion of the law whereby judgements, once delivered, stand supreme. Or

shall we reply that the city did us an injustice and did not decide the case aright? Shall we say this, or something else?

Crito: This, by Zeus, Socrates.

50b

Socrates: Well, what if the laws were to reply: “Socrates, was this also agreed between yourself and ourselves, or did you agree to abide by the judgements the city pronounced?” Now, if I were surprised that they asked this, they would probably say: “Socrates, don’t be surprised at the question, just answer it, since you make such a habit of asking and answering questions. Come on, you are attempting to destroy ourselves and the city. On what grounds? Firstly, didn’t we bring you to birth, since through us your father married your mother and begot you. So tell us, do you find any fault in those of us who are the laws concerning marriage, because they are unsound?” “I find no fault,” would be my reply. “What about those concerning the upbringing of children once they are born, and the education you yourself received? Or did those of us who were established for this purpose not issue good instructions, when they directed your father to educate you in music and gymnastics?” “They were good,” I would say.

51a

Socrates: “So be it. But since you were begotten, reared, and educated in this way, can you say firstly that you are not our offspring and our servant, you yourself and your ancestors? And if this is the case, do you think that justice between you and us is on an equal basis, and that you are justified in retaliating against anything we set about doing to you? You did not have such equality towards your father, or your master if you had one, so that you could retaliate against whatever might be done to you, either by responding to any harsh words, striking back when struck, or doing anything else of that sort. So do you think this will be permitted towards your homeland and the laws, so

that if we set about destroying you because we think it just to do so, you may also set about destroying us, the laws and your homeland, to the best of your ability, and may claim that you are justified in doing so, you, a man who truly cares so much about excellence? “Or have you, as wise as you are, overlooked the following facts: that your homeland is more worthy of respect than your mother or father or all of your other ancestors, and is more august and sacred, and more exalted in status, in the eyes of the gods and of men of intelligence; that when your homeland is angry it should be revered, obeyed and assuaged, even more than an angry father, and you should either persuade it otherwise or do as it commands, and suffer in silence if it prescribes any suffering by being beaten or imprisoned; that if it sends you to war to be wounded or slain, this is what you must do, for justice consists in this and you must not surrender or withdraw or desert your post; that in war, in a courtroom, or anywhere else, you must do what your city and your homeland commands, or else persuade it as to where justice lies; that it is unholy to use force against your father or mother, but much more so against your homeland?” What will be our reply to all this, Crito? Are the laws speaking the truth, or not?

51c

Crito: I think so.

51d

Socrates: “Then consider, Socrates,” the laws might say, “whether we are speaking the truth in saying that your actions are unjust when you set about doing what you are now doing to us. For although we begot you, nurtured you, educated you, and gave a share of all the benefits we could to yourself and all your fellow citizens, we nevertheless make an open declaration. We give permission, allowing any Athenian who wishes to take what is his and go wherever he wishes if he is displeased with us, once he has come of age and has seen what goes on in the

city and has seen ourselves, its laws. None of us laws will prevent it or forbid it if any of you want to go to a colony or go to live somewhere else as a foreigner, because we and the city are not to your liking. You may go wherever you want and take your possessions with you. “But should any of you remain, seeing the way that we administer justice and manage the city in general, we then declare that the person has agreed with us, by his action, to do whatever we order him to do. And we maintain that anyone who disobeys commits a threefold injustice: he disobeys us, we who begot him; he disobeys us, we who nurtured him; and having agreed to obey us, he neither obeys us nor persuades us otherwise if we are not acting aright, even though we lay the options before him and do not issue rough commands to do what we tell him. No, we offer two alternatives: either do as we say, or persuade us otherwise. But he does neither of these.

52b

Socrates: “Well, Socrates, we declare that if you do what you have in mind, you will be just as open to these allegations as any other Athenian, more so in fact.” And if I were to ask, “Why is that?” they would probably rebuke me, quite justifiably, saying that I, more so than any Athenian, have accepted this agreement with them. For they would declare: “Socrates, we have strong evidence that you are fond of us and of the city, for you would never have spent more time at home here than any other Athenian unless you were especially fond of her. Indeed, you have neither yet left the city to go to a festival, except once to the Isthmus, nor did you go anywhere else, except on military service, nor have you ever made any other journey abroad like other Athenians, nor have you been taken with a desire to know about another city or any different laws. No, we were good enough for you, and so was our city. You chose us, and you agreed to live under us as a citizen, with such eagerness that you even begot your children here, so much did the city

please you. And even at the trial itself you could have proposed exile as a penalty if you wanted to, and you would then have had the city's permission to do what you are now trying to do against her will. At the time, you made out that you would not be troubled if you had to die, and said you would choose death before exile. But now you are neither ashamed at your own words, nor do you show any respect for us, the laws. In an attempt to destroy us, you are doing what the basest slave might do, trying to run away, contrary to the contracts and agreements under which you contracted us to live as a citizen. So, answer this question for us first. Are we speaking the truth when we declare that you have agreed, by your actions if not by your words, to live as a citizen in accordance with us, or is this not true?" What shall we say to this, Crito? Shall we do something else, or shall we agree?

52c

Crito: We must agree, Socrates.

52d

Socrates: "In that case," they might say, "are you not contravening your contracts and agreements with us? You were not forced or deceived into agreeing, nor were you compelled to decide in a hurry. No, you had seventy years during which you could have departed if we were not to your liking, or if the agreements seemed unjust to you. But you did not prefer either Sparta or Crete, whom you have often declared to be well regulated, or any other Greek city, or any non-Greek city either. Instead, you spent less time outside the city than the lame, the blind and the other disabled folk. So you, more so than your fellow Athenians, are pleased with the city and obviously with us, the laws. For who would be pleased with a city devoid of the laws? And now, will you not abide by your agreements? You will if you heed us, Socrates, and you won't become a laughing stock by leaving the city.

52e

Socrates: “Yes, indeed, consider what good you will do to yourself, or any of your own associates, if you contravene these agreements or fall foul of them in any respect. Indeed, it is quite obvious that your associates themselves also run the risk of exile, losing their status in the city, or confiscation of their property. But taking your own case first, if you go to a nearby city such as Thebes or Megara, both of which are well regulated, you will arrive there as an enemy to their constitution, Socrates, and anyone there who cares for their own city will view you with suspicion, regarding you as a subverter of their laws, and you will confirm the opinion of the jurors and make it seem that they decided the case correctly. For presumably anyone who is a subverter of the laws will seem, most emphatically, to be a corrupter of young, unreasoning people. But what if you avoid the well-regulated cities, and the men who are most orderly? But if you do this, will you have any reason to live on? Or will you associate with these people and, without any shame, discuss what propositions, Socrates? The same ones you discuss here, that excellence and justice, regulations and the laws, are of the utmost value to people? And don't you think that the conduct of Socrates will appear unseemly? You should think so.

53e

Socrates: “Will you then keep away from these places and go instead to Thessaly, to Crito's friends, where there is indeed plenty of disorder and unrestrained behaviour, and they will probably be delighted to hear you tell of the comical way you ran away from the prison, having put on some disguise or wearing the leather garment of a peasant, or the sort of thing that runaways are usually dressed in, and how you changed your own appearance. But will no one mention the fact that as an old man, probably without much of his life remaining, you had such a greedy desire for life that you dared transgress the most important laws? Perhaps not, not if you don't upset

someone. But if you do, you will hear much that is unworthy of yourself. So you will live on, the fawning slave of everyone, doing what? Eating your fill in Thessaly, having travelled all that way for a dinner? And what will come of those arguments of ours about justice and excellence in general? “Well then, do you want to live on for the sake of your children, so that you can rear them and educate them? What about this? And once you have brought them to Thessaly, will you rear them, educate them, and make exiles of them, so that they may share in this advantage too? Or if you don’t do this and they are brought up here while you are still alive, will they be better brought up and educated when you are not with them? In fact, these associates of yours will care for your children. Is it the case that if you go off to Thessaly they will care for them, but if you go off to Hades they will not care for them? If indeed any of those who claim to be associates of yours are of any use at all, you must believe they will care for them.

54b

Socrates: “So, Socrates, heed us, we who reared you, and do not reckon children or life or anything else to be more important than justice, so that when you arrive in Hades you will be able to say all this in your own defence to those who rule there. For even here, if you do this, it will not prove better, more just, or more holy, either for you or any of those who belong to you, nor will it be better when you arrive there. Rather, as matters stand, if you depart this world you depart unjustly treated by your fellow men, and not by us, the laws. But if you escape, having returned injustice for injustice and evil for evil in such a disgraceful manner, contravening your own agreements and contracts with ourselves, and inflicting harm upon those whom you should harm least – yourself, your friends, your homeland and us – then we will be angry with you whilst you are alive, and in the next world, our brothers, the laws in Hades, will not receive you graciously knowing that you also undertook to

destroy us as best you could. So do not heed Crito, and do not do what he says. Do what we say.”

54d

Socrates: So take note, dear friend Crito. These are the words I seem to be hearing, just as the frenzied dancers seem to be hearing the pipes, and the very sound of these words is reverberating within me and makes me incapable of hearing anything else. Mark my words then. If you say anything contrary to the views I now hold, you will speak in vain. Nevertheless, if you think it will achieve anything, speak.

54e

Crito: No, Socrates, I have nothing to say.

Socrates: Well then, Crito, let it be, and let's act accordingly, since this is the way God leads us.

NOTES

1. Delos is an island sacred to Apollo. Each year the Athenians sent a ceremonial expedition to the island, and during this time it was forbidden to carry out executions in the city.
2. Sounion is a cape at the southernmost tip of the Attic peninsula, 69.5 km south-east of Athens.
3. Iliad ix.363. Phthia was the home of Achilles, so Socrates' dream presumably indicates that once he dies he will arrive home.
4. Simmias and Cebes were philosophers from Thebes. They were followers of Socrates and the Pythagorean philosopher Philolaos, and are the main interlocutors in Plato's *Phaedo*.
5. Thessaly is a region of Greece that lies north-west of Athens.

Epistles

ΕΠΙΣΤΟΛΑΙ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

PLATO *author, of Alopecce, Athens*

DIONYSIUS II *tyrant of Syracuse*

DION *of Syracuse*

ARCHYTAS *of Tarentum*

scene: Letters written by Plato to various recipients, c. 366–353 BCE

FIRST EPISTLE Plato to Dionysius: may you do well

309a

Although I spent so much time with you, administering your rule and being trusted more than anyone, you received the benefits while I endured the vexatious slanders. For I knew that people would not think I co-operated in enacting any of your more cruel deeds since I have, as my witnesses, all those who are involved in government along with you, many of whom I have assisted and saved from no small harm. And although I have often protected your city on my own authority, I was sent away with less respect than befits a beggar, banished by you, ordered to sail away having spent so much time with you. Hereafter, I shall consider my own interest, adopting a less human approach, while you, being the tyrant that you are, will dwell alone.

309c

As for the glistening gold you gave me on my departure, Baccheius, the bearer of this letter, is returning it. For it was neither adequate to provide for my journey, nor beneficial for my life in general, and its provision reflects very badly on your reputation as the donor, and not much less upon mine as the recipient. That's why I have not accepted it. Of course, to receive or give such a sum makes no difference to you, so now that you have it back, use it to serve another one of your associates just as you did in my case, for I have had enough of

your services. And it is timely for me to quote Euripides, that should other misfortunes ever befall you, “You'll pray that such a man be by your side.” And I wish to remind you that most of the other tragedians, when they present a tyrant on stage being slain by someone, they have him cry out, “Bereft of friends, wretched, I perish.” But none of them portrays him as perishing for want of gold. The following lines too seem sensible to sensible people: It is not gold, though a shining rarity in mortals' hopeless life, nor gems nor silver couches, that brighten the eyes of men, nor broad and self-sufficient fields laden with the harvest, but the approving thought of upright men. Farewell, and please recognise how much advantage you have failed to obtain from us, so that you may behave better towards others.

SECOND EPISTLE Plato to Dionysius: may you do well

310c

I have heard from Archedemus that you think not only that I myself should say nothing about you, but that my friends too should neither do nor say anything bad concerning you. You made an exception in the case of Dion only, but your argument that Dion is an exception implies that I do not have control over my own friends. But what you should do in future, I think, if anyone reports anything of this sort about any of us, is to write to me and ask me about it. For I shall be neither reluctant nor ashamed to speak the truth.

310d

As for yourself and myself and our dealings with one another: both of us are, in a sense, known to every Greek. And our relationship is no secret. Why am I saying this now? It is natural that wisdom and great power combine somehow, and they constantly pursue and seek one another. For instance,

whenever people talk about Hiero, or Pausanias of Sparta, they love to bring in their association with Simonides and what he did and said to them. And they are in the habit of celebrating Periander of Corinth and Thales of Miletus together, Pericles and Anaxagoras too, and indeed Croesus and Solon, both wise, with the powerful Cyrus. Then, the poets too, imitating these relationships, bring together Creon with Tiresias, Polyeidus with Minos, Agamemnon with Nestor, and Odysseus with Palamedes.

311a

I am saying all this because I wish to demonstrate that when we both die, the stories told about us will not be silenced, and so we need to be careful about them. Now, in our case, it is still possible, God willing, if anything improper has been done in the course of our relationship heretofore, to correct this in word and in deed. For I maintain that if we are reasonable, true philosophy will be better regarded and better spoken of, but if we are corrupt, that will have the opposite effect.

311d

Now, I shall explain how we should proceed and where justice lies. I arrived in Sicily with the reputation of being the most distinguished of those engaged in philosophy, and when I got to Syracuse I wanted to involve you in my cause so that I might see philosophy honoured even by the general public. But the outcome was not propitious for me. The explanation I give is that you appeared not to trust me very much and wanted to get rid of me and send for others instead, and out of mistrust, to find out what my business was. With that there was a general clamour declaring that you despised me and had more important matters to attend to.

312b

What, then, is the right thing to do next? If you have total contempt for philosophy, then bid it farewell, and if you have heard better instruction than mine from elsewhere, or have

discovered better yourself, then respect those discoveries. But if my teachings are pleasing to you, you should also have special respect for me. So now, as in the beginning, you should take the lead and I shall follow. For if I am respected by you I shall have respect for you, but if I am not respected, I shall keep quiet. To sum up then, if you show respect, it is a credit to us both, whereas if I show respect, it is a reproach to us both.

312d

The sphere is not correct, as Archedemus will explain when he arrives. And he really needs to explain the other matter, more venerable and divine than the sphere, which was perplexing you when you dispatched him. Now, it must be related to you in riddles so that if anything happens to the writing tablet in the recesses of sea or land, whoever reads it will not understand it. It says that everything is around the King of All, and everything is for the sake of that king, the cause of all that is good. Around the second are the second things, while the third things are around the third. The human soul hungers to learn about what sort of things these are by looking to the things that are kindred to itself, none of which are adequate. This question, dear son of Dionysius and Doris, or rather, the travail about it engendered in the soul, is responsible for all difficulties. And unless a person frees himself from this he shall never really encounter the truth.

313b

But you told me in the garden under the laurels that you had thought of this yourself and that it was your discovery, and I replied that if this proved to be the case, you would be sparing me from lengthy discussions. Since although you think you are in possession of unassailable proofs, you have not established them securely, and so for you it flits around about the appearance, now in one direction, now in another. But the reality is not like this.

313d

Now that all this has happened, we have more or less found the answer to the question in your letter as to how we should behave towards one another. For since you have tested my arguments by associating with others and comparing my arguments to theirs, if your test is a true one they shall begin to grow within you, and you shall be familiar with them and with us. You were right in sending Archedemus, and if you do this two or three times, and sufficiently test the answers sent from me, I would be surprised if your present difficulties did not take on a very different aspect than now.

314a

However, you must be careful that these communications are never disclosed to uneducated folk, for to most people hardly any words sound more laughable than these, while on the other hand, to those with a natural affinity, none are more wonderfully inspiring. And being frequently repeated and constantly heard over many years, they are with much effort gradually rendered as pure as gold. There are people, many of them, who have heard these words and are now at a point where they say that what had once seemed utterly unbelievable to them now appears most credible and obvious. The greatest safeguard is to avoid writing and to learn by heart, for it is inevitable that what is written down will be disclosed. That is why I have never yet written about these matters, nor is there a written work of Plato, nor will there ever be, and those writings that are now said to be mine belong to a Socrates become fair and young. Farewell and believe. And now, first read this letter many times, then commit it to the flames.

314d

Enough of this. As for Polyxenus, you were surprised that I sent him to you, but I give the same report now as in the past about Lycrophron and the others who are with you. When it comes to dialogue you are far superior to them by nature and in your method of argument. Indeed, it seems to me that you treat them

and reward them in a measured way. If you have use for Phylition, employ him yourself by all means, but if possible please send him to Speusippus and let him employ the man. Speusippus himself asks you to do this too. You did well to release that man from the quarries. And the truth deserves to be spoken about Lysicleides, for he is the only Sicilian who, on arriving in Athens, did not misrepresent the relationship between the two of us. He continues, rather, to speak well and to find something good to say about what transpired.

THIRD EPISTLE Plato to Dionysius: may you have joy

315b

Having written thus, may I, perhaps, have hit upon the best mode of address? Or might it be better to follow my usual practice and write “may you do well”, which is the greeting I habitually use in letters to friends? You yourself, of course, addressed the god at Delphi with this fawning utterance, writing, “I wish you joy and that you may preserve a pleasant tyrant’s life,” whereas I would not greet any human, or indeed a god, by calling upon them to do this. In the case of gods, my injunction would run contrary to their nature, for the divine is situated at a far remove from pleasure and pain. And in the case of humanity, pleasure and pain are for the most part harmful, engendering dullness, forgetfulness, folly and arrogance in the soul.

315d

I am informed, by no small number of people, that you told some of the ambassadors in your circle that I once overheard you saying that you were going to colonise the Greek cities in Sicily, and lighten the burden of the Syracusans by changing the rulership to kingship instead of tyranny. But according to you, I prevented you from doing all this at the time, whereas I am now

instructing Dion to enact these very measures, thus using your own ideas to take your rulership away from you. But you do me an injustice when you speak contrary to the facts, for I have been slandered enough by Philistides and many others. But you yourself know full well that I willingly co-operated with you on a few of your political measures in the beginning when I thought this might do some good.

316c

I came to Syracuse at the behest of yourself and Dion, who was a long-standing, tried and trusted friend of mine. He was middle-aged and settled, two prerequisites for those of even a little intelligence when they are about to give advice on affairs as important as yours at the time. You, on the other hand, were very young and very inexperienced in those matters in which you needed experience. Afterwards, some person or some god or some random event, with your involvement, expelled Dion and you alone remained. Do you think I would associate with you politically when, having lost my wise associate, I beheld only the unwise one left behind, surrounded by lots of degenerate men, not ruling but thinking he was ruling? I bade farewell to political affairs thereafter, being wary of the slanders and jealousies, and I endeavoured by all means to make the two of you the best of friends.

317a

And although it was difficult, the two of us nevertheless agreed that I should sail home since you were involved in a war, and that when peace came, Dion and I were to return to Syracuse and you were to send for us. When peace came you sent for me, but not in accordance with the agreement. You wrote that I was to come alone, and you said you would send for Dion later. Because of this I did not go. After this, a year later, a trireme arrived along with letters from you, and the chief purport of what was contained in the letters was that if I were to come to Syracuse, Dion's affairs would be organised in accord with my

wishes, whereas if I did not, the outcome would be the very opposite.

317c

You know of course what happened after I arrived. In fact, I asked, in accord with the agreement in our letters, firstly, that Dion be restored and that you be reconciled with him. Secondly, I asked that Dion's relatives retain his property and that the annual revenue usually sent to him should continue to be sent. When none of these requests were granted, I asked if I could depart. You then started persuading me to stay for the year, saying that you were selling all Dion's property and were going to send half of the proceeds to Corinth. But, you surprising man, you then topped all of your promises most insolently. For when you expelled Heraclides, an action that neither the Syracusans nor I myself regarded as just, you said that it had been obvious to you for a long time that I thought nothing of you, but only of Dion and his friends.

318e

The argument comes more or less to the second statement against which I must defend myself. I confirm that, with Archedemus present in the garden, along with Aristocritus, some twenty days before I left Syracuse for home, you said then what you are now saying in your criticism of me, that I favoured Heraclides and all the others more than yourself. And you asked me if I remembered when I first arrived calling upon you to colonise the Greek cities. I agreed that I did remember and that I still thought this to be the best policy. But I must also repeat what was said next. For I then asked you whether this was the only piece of advice I gave you or whether there was something else besides this. And you answered me most angrily and contemptuously. You said, I recall, with much feigned laughter, "You bade me to do all of these things after I had been educated, or not do them at all." I replied that your recollection was excellent.

319d

Now, the reason I am saying all this is as follows. Do not slander me by saying that I did not allow you to colonise the Greek cities ruined by the non-Greeks, or to lighten the burden of the Syracusans by introducing kingly rule in place of the tyranny. For in my case, no lie you could ever tell about me is less appropriate than these slanders. And indeed, there is no difficulty in stating plainly that the implementation of these measures was the best course for you, the Syracusans, and for all Sicilians. But, my friend, if you deny saying these things, even though you said them, then justice lies with me. But if you agree that you said them, you should then regard Stesichorus as wise, imitate his recantation, and renounce your false account for the true one.

FOURTH EPISTLE Plato to Dion of Syracuse: may you do well

320a

I believe that my eager interest in the unfolding events has been evident all along, and also my serious concern that they be brought to a conclusion, mainly because of my high regard for noble deeds. For I think it is only right that those who are actually reasonable and who act accordingly should get the recognition they deserve. And although for the moment, thank God, things are going well, the greatest struggle is still to come. For although various others may seem to excel in courage, speed and strength, anyone would agree that those who claim to honour such qualities as truth, justice, and high-mindedness, and decorum in their display of all these, are naturally superior to others.

320c

We need to make it obvious that we are the sort of people we say we are, especially since, God willing, it will be easy to do so. For other people, it proves necessary to wander abroad if they

are to be well known, but with you the position is that people everywhere all look towards one place, and in that place they look most of all towards yourself. So, with the eyes of the world upon you, prepare to take on the role of a Lysurgus or a Cyrus of old. This is especially important since many people are saying that with Dionysius out of the way, there is a strong possibility that your endeavours will come to naught because of the rivalry between yourself, Heraclides, Theodotus, and other notable ambitious characters. Let us hope above all that no one behaves like this, but if anyone does so, you must assume the role of a healer.

320e

Perhaps the fact that I am saying this appears comical to you since you yourself are not unaware of these details. But I observe that in the theatres, the actors are spurred on even by the children, not to mention their friends, provided the actor thinks the encouragement is serious and well-intentioned. So, you yourselves should now act out your parts, and if you need anything just write to us. And now, in spite of the fact that letters arrived in Sparta and Aegina from Theodorus and Heraclides, we still hear much but know nothing. But also bear in mind that you seem to some people to lack the appropriate level of care. So, do not overlook the fact that pleasing other people is a means to acting successfully whereas self-will is the housemate of loneliness. Good fortune.

FIFTH EPISTLE Plato to Perdiccas: may you do well

321a

I advised Euphraeus, at your request, to spend time looking after your affairs. And it is only right that I give you friendly and so-called sacred advice about the other issues you mentioned and as to how you should now employ Euphraeus. The man is useful in many respects, but the greatest is one that

you stand in need of because of your youth. For each political system has its own language, just like various animals, one belonging to democracy, another to oligarchy, another to monarchy. And although everyone claims to know these, most people, with few exceptions, fall short of fully understanding them. Now, whatever political system utters its own language towards gods or men, and makes its actions conform to its utterance, thrives and is preserved. But if it imitates another, it is undone.

321c

Euphraeus should prove useful to you for these purposes at least, and he is also a good man in other respects too. So, by using him for these purposes you will benefit yourself and also be of enormous benefit to him. But if someone were to say, “It seems that Plato pretends to know what is of benefit to the democracy, but despite being allowed to address the populace and advise them as to what is best, he has never yet stood up and uttered a word,” you should respond: “Plato was born at a late stage in the history of his fatherland, and he came upon a populace already advanced in years and habituated by their predecessors to many practices incompatible with Plato’s advice. He would have been most delighted to give advice to the populace, had he not thought that he would be running risks in vain and accomplishing nothing worthwhile.” Good fortune.

SIXTH EPISTLE Plato to Hermias¹⁰, Erastus and Coriscus: may you do well

322d

It is apparent to me that some god has graciously and adequately provided you with good fortune, if you can receive it well. For you live as neighbours and your needs are such that you are of great benefit to one another. As for Hermias, neither abundance of horses nor other military resources nor

accumulated gold would contribute more to his overall power than firm friends of sound character. And to Erastus and Coriscus, in spite of my age, I am saying they should supplement the noble wisdom of the forms with a wisdom and protective power that defends them against the wicked and the unjust. For they are lacking in experience because they have lived out much of their lives with us moderate folk who are not evil.

323a

So what am I saying? To you Hermias, since I am more familiar with Erastus and Coriscus than you are, I assert, declare and bear witness that you will not easily find more trustworthy characters than these neighbours of yours, and I advise you to cleave to these two men by every just means as a matter of no secondary importance. And again, I am advising Coriscus and Erastus to cleave to Hermias and try to develop your mutual closeness into a united relationship of friendship. But if one of you somehow seems to be severing this relationship, for nothing human is entirely firm, send me and my associates here a letter declaring the nature of the complaint. For I believe that unless the breach happens to be grievous, any communications arriving from us here in justice and reverence would do more than any charm to unite you, and restore once again your previous ties of friendship and fellowship.

323c

And if we all, yourselves and ourselves, apply philosophy to this fellowship as best we can, as the nature of each allows, the prophecies I am making will prevail. All three of you should read this letter, preferably together or in pairs, in fellowship to the best of your ability, as often as you can. Use it as a covenant and a supreme law, a just one, swearing earnestly, and at the same time poetically, with a playfulness akin to that earnestness. Swearing to the ruling god of everything that is now and is to come, supreme father of the ruling cause, whom we, if we genuinely engage in philosophy, shall all clearly know

as far as possible for happy humans.

SEVENTH EPISTLE Plato to the relatives and associates of Dion: may ye fare well

323e

You wrote to me that I should regard your thinking as being the same as that of Dion, and indeed you encouraged me to support you to the best of my ability in word and in deed. I reply that if you actually hold the same opinion and aspiration as that man, I promise to support you, but if you don't, this will require further consideration. And I can tell you from certain knowledge, without much need for conjecture, what his thinking and aspiration was. For when I arrived initially in Syracuse, aged about forty, Dion was the same age as Hipparinus is now, and he held the opinion then that he held to the very end. He thought that the Syracusans should be free people living under the very best laws.

324a

When I was young, my experience was the same as many others. I thought that as soon as I had become my own master I would immediately enter into the public life of the city. For the political system at the time, being criticised by many, was overthrown, and fifty-one men set themselves up as leaders of that overthrow. Some of these happened to be relatives or acquaintances of mine, and indeed they encouraged me to join them as their undertakings were worthwhile. My feelings towards them were hardly surprising given my youth, for I thought they would administer the city by leading it out of an unjust manner of life to a just one.

324c

And of course, I saw that these men did not take long to make the previous political arrangement look like a golden age. Among their various exploits, they also sent for Socrates, an

elderly man who was dear to me, whom I would almost say unashamedly was the most just man alive at that time. They dispatched him, along with some others, to fetch one of our fellow citizens by force so that they could execute him. But he did not obey them, and he ran the risk of all sorts of consequences rather than getting involved in their unholy deeds. Seeing all this, and other actions that were just as bad, I was disgusted, and withdrew myself from the evils of that era.

325a

But as it happened, again with this companion of ours, Socrates, influential people prosecuted him, bringing a most despicable accusation against him. They charged him with impiety, while others convicted him, and condemned to death the very man who had refused to get involved in the impious plot against one of their own exiled friends. Watching these developments, and seeing the sort of people who were conducting our political affairs and the state of our laws and habits, the more I saw, as I advanced in years, just how difficult it appeared to be to manage civic affairs in the right way. For it is impossible to do this without friends and trustworthy associates, and to find such people readily available was not easy.

325d

And I was compelled to say, in praise of right philosophy, that from this it is possible to discern all that is just in the political realm and among individuals. So, the evils of the human race shall not cease until either the sort of people who engage in philosophy, rightly and truly, come to power in political affairs, or those who exercise power in cities, by some divine portion, actually engage in philosophy. This was my thinking when I arrived in Italy¹⁵ and Sicily for my first visit. When I got there, the so-called 'happy life', replete with Italian and Syracusan banquets, did not please me at all. They live their lives, gorging themselves on food twice a day, never sleeping alone at night. For with such habits as these no human being under heaven

could ever become wise, nor could anyone ever become sound-minded.

326e

Holding these views as well as the earlier ones, I travelled to Syracuse, perhaps by chance, although it seems that some higher power then set in train the events which have now unfolded concerning Dion and Syracuse. When I met Dion, who was young at the time, and I explained in discussion what I believed to be best for humanity, and advised him to act on these precepts, I seemed unaware that I was somehow or other bringing about the impending overthrow of the tyranny without appreciating what I was doing. Now, Dion learnt very easily in general, and he listened with more keen attention than any young person I have ever come across to the subjects that my discourses dealt with. And he was willing to live the rest of his life in a different way from most of the Italians and Sicilians, for he had come to cherish excellence more than pleasure and general luxury.

327c

After this, Dion concluded that such thinking, which he himself had arrived at through proper discourse, would not always be confined to himself. He thought that Dionysius might perhaps, with the assistance of the gods, become one of those who pursued such thinking. What's more, if such a development took place, the result would be a life of unbounded blessedness for himself and the rest of the Syracusans. Furthermore, Dion thought I should, by all means, get to Syracuse as soon as possible to join him in these endeavours. His request went as follows: "What greater opportunities are we waiting for than those that have now been presented by some divine good fortune?" He described in detail the Italian and Sicilian empire, and his own influence therein, how young Dionysius was, and the intense desire he had for philosophy and education.

328a

In the end I decided on balance that it was necessary to go. If anyone was ever to attempt to implement those thoughts about laws and political systems, now was the time to make the attempt, for by sufficiently convincing just one person, I would have brought about all sorts of benefits. Emboldened by this thinking, I sailed away from my homeland, most of all from a sense of shame on my own part in case I might seem to myself, well and truly, to be some mere word, unwilling to engage in any action whatsoever. By going, I freed myself in the eyes of Zeus, the god of strangers, and put myself beyond reproach on the part of philosophy, which would have been criticised had I disgraced myself through weakness of spirit and base cowardice. On arrival, to keep the story short, I found the circle around Dionysius full of all sorts of faction and slanders brought to the regime against Dion.

329c

Although I defended him to the best of my ability, there was little I could do. And within four months or so, Dionysius accused Dion of plotting against his tyranny, put him on a small boat, and expelled him ignominiously. After this, we, the friends of Dion, were afraid that one of us might be accused and punished for being an accomplice in Dion's plot. Being aware of how we felt, Dionysius received us all in a kindly spirit, and he reassured myself in particular, encouraging me to take heart and asking me in all sorts of ways to remain. For my departure from him would not have been to his credit, but my remaining with him would have been, and that is why he made a great pretence of imploring me to stay.

329e

But we know that the requests of tyrants are always mixed with compulsion, and so he made arrangements to prevent my departure, bringing me to the acropolis and housing me where no ship's captain would take me away, unless Dionysius himself sent them a written instruction to do so. As time went on,

Dionysius became steadily more affectionate as he grew familiar with my manner and character, and he wanted me to praise him more than Dion and to regard him as a more special friend than Dion. But he was reluctant to learn discourses concerning philosophy in close company with myself, fearing the words of the slanderers. I endured all this, preserving my initial thinking with which I had arrived in Sicily, hoping that he would somehow come to desire the life of philosophy, but he succeeded in resisting this.

330c

These were all the circumstances involved in my visit to Sicily and my activities there on the first occasion. After this I departed, only to return once more at the most urgent request of Dionysius. But first I am to advise you about what you should do under the present circumstances. When advising a sick man whose lifestyle is injurious to his health, isn't it necessary in the first place to effect a change in his way of life, and give the rest of the advice only when he is willing to comply? But if he proves unwilling, I would regard someone who stops advising such a person as a manly physician, while someone who persists, I regard as an unmanly, unskilled physician. And the same holds for a city. But there are people who go completely away from the correct political system and have no desire whatsoever to follow in its path. They warn any adviser to leave the system as it is and not to disturb it, or they will put him to death. Anyone who persists in advising such people I regard as unmanly, and those who do not persist I regard as manly.

331c

This, indeed, is the manner in which I would advise you, just as I, along with Dion, advised Dionysius, telling him firstly to live each day of his life in such a way as to be, most of all, master of himself, possessed of trustworthy friends and companions. This would ensure that he did not suffer the same fate as his own father, who annexed many great Sicilian cities that had been

plundered by the non-Greeks, but was unable when he had colonised them to establish reliable political systems in any of them composed of men who were comrades. And there is no greater indicator of one's excellence or lack of excellence than being bereft of such people or not.

332d

Since this was what had happened to his father, myself and Dion gave this advice to Dionysius, who had had no exposure to education or to appropriate company in the first place. He was advised to acquire other friends for himself from among his kindred, friends of a similar age with an affinity for excellence. But he was advised above all to acquire such affinity for himself, for he was remarkably deficient in this. Without speaking in such plain terms, for it was unsafe to do so, we hinted at this, and we maintained in argument that this is how any man is to save himself and those for whom he is responsible. Proceeding as we suggested, if he were then to colonise the abandoned Sicilian cities and bind them to himself and to one another against the leagues of non-Greeks, we told him that he would not merely double the size of his father's empire, but actually make it many times larger.

333b

These were the words of exhortation to Dionysius from ourselves, who, according to reports pouring in from all quarters, were conspiring against him. Such reports eventually led to Dionysius' expulsion of Dion, and put us in a state of fear. Now, to deal briefly with a number of events, when Dion returned from the Peloponnese and Athens he taught Dionysius a practical lesson. When Dion had liberated the Syracusans and given them back their city on two occasions, they had the same attitude towards him as Dionysius had when Dion tried to educate him and train him to be a king worthy of authority. These allegations prevailed for the second time among the Syracusans, and their prevalence was a bizarre and shameful

victory for those who were responsible for this.

333d

I, a citizen of Athens, a companion of Dion, his ally, went to the tyrant with the aim of converting hostility into friendship, but I lost my struggle against the slanderers. Yet, when Dionysius tried to use money and honours to persuade me to testify, as a friend, to the appropriateness of his expulsion of Dion, he failed utterly in his endeavours. Later, as Dion was returning home, he attached himself to two brothers from Athens who had become his friends, not from a love of wisdom but from ordinary companionship. And, indeed, these two friends, having joined him for his return, became his companions. But when they arrived in Sicily, once they saw that Dion was being slandered for plotting to become a tyrant by the very Sicilians he had liberated, not only did they betray their comrade and host, but they became more or less directly involved in his murder, for they stood by the murderers as allies, with weapons in their hands.

334c

All this has been said by way of advice to Dion's friends and associates. But I now give you some additional advice, delivering the same advice and the same argument for the third time to yourselves as the third recipients. This is what I say. Do not subjugate Sicily or any other city to human despots, but to laws. For subjugation is good neither for the subjugated nor for those who subjugate them, neither for themselves, their children nor their children's children. The first person I tried to convince of this was Dion, the second was Dionysius, and you yourselves are now third. Be persuaded then by me, for the sake of Zeus, the third, the saviour¹⁶, looking either to the case of Dionysius or of Dion, one of whom was unpersuaded and is now living an ignoble life while the other was persuaded and died a noble death.

335a

We should always be truly persuaded by the ancient, sacred pronouncements which tell us that soul is immortal, that it has judges and pays great retribution when someone quits the body. That is why we should regard it as a lesser evil to suffer great wrongs and injustices rather than perform them. With these arguments, and others like them, I set about persuading Dion, and I would have very good grounds for being angry with those who murdered the man, and similarly with Dionysius, for both parties did enormous damage to me, and in a sense to all of humanity in general. The murderers did this by destroying a man who was intent upon practising justice, while Dionysius, despite his great power throughout his entire empire, refused to practise justice.

336a

Now, factions have no rest from their evils until those who have won power stop revisiting past evils through open warfare, expulsion and slaughter, and give up the search for revenge upon their enemies, and exercise some control over themselves by passing laws that are common to all, involving no more advantage to themselves than to the defeated parties. They should compel these people to have recourse to the laws by employing two necessary forces, reverence and fear. Otherwise there is no way that a city with internal factions will ever abate its evils. Rather, for cities constituted in this way, factions, enmity, hatred and suspicion, internal to themselves, tend to arise unrelentingly.

337b

So those who have won power should always, once they are truly desirous of security, select from among themselves the very best Greeks they can find, men who firstly are advanced in years, who have households of wives and children, and preferably ancestors aplenty, who are good, reputable and all sufficiently well off. Fifty such people should suffice for a city of ten thousand citizens. Once the laws have been enacted, it is

all-important that the victors render themselves more subservient to the laws than the vanquished. Then everyone will be safe, happiness will abound, and all the evils will be avoided. So, that's enough advice and direction about my first visit to Dionysius.

338b

Once peace had been restored Dionysius began sending for me, and although he asked Dion to wait a further year, he made all sorts of requests for me to come. Dion kept asking and imploring me to travel, and indeed there was much report from Sicily that Dionysius had now become marvelously enthusiastic about philosophy once again. Nevertheless, it seemed safer at the time to stay well away from Dion and Dionysius, and I annoyed them both by replying that I was advanced in years. After this it seems that Archytas visited the court of Dionysius. In fact, before my departure I had forged a bond of hospitality and friendship between Archytas and his people in Tarentum and Dionysius.

338d

In fact, Dionysius, on the third occasion, sent a trireme to make the journey easier for me, and he sent Archidamus, an associate of Archytas. He himself sent a very long letter, knowing full well of my relationship with Dion and Dion's eagerness that I make the journey and visit Syracuse. In fact, the letter dealt with all these considerations, beginning with: "Dionysius to Plato", followed by the usual civilities. And then, without further ado, it said, "If you are persuaded by us and come forthwith to Sicily, then first and foremost Dion's affairs will be arranged for you in whatever way you wish. But if you don't travel, none of Dion's affairs will unfold to your satisfaction." Other letters kept arriving from Archytas and his people in Tarentum, praising the philosophy of Dionysius. So I felt that I should unequivocally test how matters actually stood.

339d

So, clothed in this reasoning, I went on my way with many fears and, as you might expect, a considerable foreboding. It really was a case of ‘the third to the saviour’. Yet fortunately I came through safely once again, and for this, after God, I must be grateful to Dionysius, for although many people were intent upon my destruction, he prevented this. Once I had arrived there, I decided first of all to test whether Dionysius really was inflamed by the fire of philosophy. There is a way of putting such matters to the test which is not crude and really well suited to tyrants. It is necessary to point out to such people what the subject is in its entirety, the sort of subject it is, and how much complexity and effort it involves. Someone who hears this, if he be really philosophic, will believe that he has heard something wonderful and that he should now bestir himself. But those who are not really philosophic, having a mere coating of opinions, once they see how many subjects are involved and the extent of the exertion, they decide that philosophy is difficult and beyond their abilities.

341a

Now, I can say this much about those who have written or shall write, claiming to have knowledge of the subjects I take seriously, having learned from myself or from others, or having made the discoveries themselves. They could not, in my opinion, understand anything about the matter, for there is no writing of mine dealing with these subjects, nor will there ever be. Indeed, this cannot be expressed in words like other subjects, but from much engagement with the matter itself, and from living with it a light is kindled as though from a leaping spark, and once it has arisen in the soul it sustains itself thereafter. But if it had appeared to me that this was sufficiently capable of being written down and formulated in words for people in general, what task could I have undertaken in my life more exalted than this one: to write something enormously beneficial for mankind, and bring the nature of reality to light

for all to behold?

342a

But it occurs to me to speak at greater length about these issues. There is indeed a true argument that stands against anyone who ventures to write anything at all about this sort of thing. For any of the things that exist, there are in each case three things through which the knowledge of anything is necessarily acquired. The knowledge itself is fourth, and as a fifth we must propose the thing itself, which is cognisable and which truly is. First is a name, second is an account, third is an image, and fourth is knowledge. Take one example: there is something called a circle, which has the very name we have just uttered. Second is the account of this, composed of names and verbs – that which has its extremities everywhere equidistant from the centre. Third is that which is drawn and erased, turned on a lathe and destroyed, none of which happens to circle itself. Fourth is knowledge, true reason and opinion about these, which are not contained in utterances or in physical shapes, but in souls. Of these, reason comes closest in kinship and similarity to the fifth, the circle itself.

343b

Now, although the unsoundness of each of the four is an endless topic of discussion, what's most important is that there are two things: what something is and what it is like. And although soul does not seek to know what something is like but what it is, each of the four offers the soul that which it seeks not, and always provides something that is easily refuted by the senses, thus filling almost everybody with perplexity and insecurity of all sorts. But instruction through all these, going upwards and downwards in each case, with effort brings knowledge to birth of that which is good by nature in one who is good by nature. That is why anyone who is serious about really serious matters should never commit them to writing and thus expose them to the rivalry and confusion of humanity in general.

344d

Anyone who has followed this story and digression of mine will appreciate full well that whether Dionysius has written about the primary principles of nature, or some lesser or greater person has done so, then, according to my account, he has not learned or understood anything sound about the matters on which he has written. Nor did he write this down as an aid to memory, for once someone has grasped this with his soul there is no danger that he might forget it. If he did actually write, he did so out of base ambition, as if he was presenting his own ideas or as if he had received an education of which he was not worthy, all from a love of the fame associated with its possession.

345c

Not long afterwards, although Dionysius had previously allowed Dion to retain his possessions and to derive income from them, he then no longer allowed Dion's trustees to send anything to the Peloponnese, as if he had completely forgotten about his own letter. He now maintained that the property belonged not to Dion but to his son, who was his own nephew and under his legal guardianship. These were the developments during my stay up to this point. But when matters unfolded in this way, I saw exactly the extent of Dionysius' desire for philosophy, and I had good reason to be annoyed. I thought I should tell Dionysius that because Dion had been treated so badly, it would be impossible for me to stay.

346a

But Dionysius came up with a plan to detain me for that sailing season. He arrived the following day and presented this persuasive argument: "You and I must get Dion and his affairs out of the way and get rid of our constant disputes over these issues. For your sake I will do the following for Dion. I think it best that he takes his property and lives on the Peloponnese, not as an exile, but with permission to return home here

whenever this is agreed jointly by himself, by me, and by yourselves, his friends. So consider whether these proposals are acceptable to you, and stay for this year on these conditions, and next season you may take the money and depart.” When I heard this proposal I was annoyed. Nevertheless, I told him that I would give him my views on the matter the next day when I had thought about it.

347a

Having made my decisions, I told Dionysius the following day: “I have decided to stay, but I ask you not to presume that I have authority over Dion, but send a letter to him, jointly with myself, explaining what has now been agreed, and asking whether this is acceptable to him. Meanwhile, you should implement no new measures affecting Dion.” This is what was said, and this, more or less, was what we agreed upon. After this, the ships sailed away. It was no longer possible for me to depart. But Dionysius followed up on his proposals in a most high-handed manner by selling Dion’s property, in its entirety, as he pleased, to whomsoever he pleased, without saying anything to me about these plans.

348a

Until these developments took place, I had been acting in support of philosophy and my friends, but afterwards, Dionysius and I lived differently. I was looking outwards like a bird yearning to fly away from the place, while he was working out how he might intimidate me without giving away any of Dion’s property. Then, contrary to the practice of his father, Dionysius tried to reduce the pay of his older mercenaries. But the soldiers, being angry, banded together and charged the walls, shouting some barbaric war cry, at which Dionysius became fearful and conceded all the demands. Word quickly spread that Heraclides had been responsible for these troubles, and when the man heard this he took himself off and disappeared, while Dionysius tried to capture him.

348c

He summoned Theodotes to the garden where I happened to be walking at the time. I know and remember what Theodotes said to Dionysius in my presence: "Plato, I am in the process of persuading Dionysius here that should I prove capable of getting Heraclides to come here to discuss the accusations that have now been made against him, I think it best that he set sail for the Peloponnese, taking his wife and son, and dwell there without being a threat to Dionysius. I ask and implore Dionysius, should someone come across Heraclides, either in the countryside or here in the city, let no harm come to him apart from being deported from this land." Then, addressing Dionysius, he said, "Do you agree with this?" "I agree," said he. "And even if he turns up in your own home, he shall suffer no harm beyond what has just been said."

349a

The next day, during the afternoon, Eurybius and Theodotes came to me in a hurry, remarkably troubled, and Theodotes said, "Plato, you were present yesterday when Dionysius entered into an agreement with both of us in relation to Heraclides, were you not?" "Of course," I replied. "Well, right now," said he, "there are peltasts running around seeking to apprehend Heraclides. But you really need to come with us to Dionysius." So we set off, gained admission, and while the other two stood tearfully in silence, I said, "My friends here are afraid that you might do something high-handed in relation to Heraclides, contrary to what we agreed yesterday." When Dionysius heard this he was enraged. But I said, "Take heart, Theodotes, for Dionysius will never be so bold to do anything contrary to what was agreed yesterday." But Dionysius, in a highly tyrannical manner, said, "With you I agreed nothing, great or small." "Yes you did, by the gods," said I. "You agreed not to do the very things this man is now asking you not to do." And with these words I turned around and walked out.

349c

After this, Dionysius continued to hunt down Heraclides. According to reports, Heraclides was a few hours ahead of them and escaped into Carthaginian territory. After this, his ongoing plan to hold onto Dion's property seemed to afford Dionysius a convincing basis for enmity with myself. First, he expelled me from the acropolis. While I was staying outside the acropolis, Theodotes sent for me, and complained at length about everything that had happened. He then indicated to me that I was not acting at all well in attaching more importance to Dion and his friends than to Dionysius himself.

349e

Thereafter, I was residing outside the acropolis among the mercenaries. Various people came to me, including some ships' rowers who were fellow citizens from Athens, advising me that damaging stories about me were spreading amongst the peltasts, some of whom were threatening to kill me if they ever got their hands on me. So, I sent word to Archytas and other friends in Tarentum, explaining the predicament I happened to be in. Under the pretext of an embassy from their city, they sent a thirty-oared boat and also one of their own people, Lamiskus, who, on arrival, made a request to Dionysius concerning myself, saying that I wished to depart, and asking that he do nothing whatsoever to stop me. He agreed, and sent me on my way having given me provisions for the journey.

350b

On reaching the Peloponnese at Olympia I came across Dion, who was a spectator at the Games, and I told him all that happened. He, calling upon Zeus as his witness, immediately exhorted myself and my associates and friends to make arrangements to take revenge on Dionysius. Having heard this, I encouraged him to call upon my friends to help him if they wished to do so. "As for myself," said I, "it was you, along with others, who somehow forced me to share the table and hearth

of Dionysius and join in his sacred rites. And although he probably believed that I was plotting along with you against himself and the tyranny, he nevertheless did not have me put to death, but showed me respect. Now, I am no longer really at an age to be of military assistance to anybody, but if you ever feel the need for friendship towards one another and wish to do one another some good, I am fully available to both sides.”

351a

Dion had the same intention as I would attribute to myself or, indeed, anyone else who is reasonable and intends to confer the greatest benefits in terms of power and honour on himself, his friends and his own city to the greatest possible extent. For neither Dion nor anyone else ever intentionally pursues power that will be a curse for all time to himself and his family. They pursue, rather, a political system and the provision of the best and most just laws, introduced without any murders or slayings. This is what Dion was engaged in at the time, preferring to suffer unrighteous deeds rather than perform them. For a righteous person, being sound-minded and sensible, would never wholly be deceived about the souls of any unrighteous people he was dealing with. This same failure brought Dion down, for although he was fully aware that those who brought him down were bad people, he failed to notice the height of ignorance they had attained, and their general depravity and greed, and because he overlooked this he now lies fallen, bringing countless misfortunes upon Sicily. As for the situation following the events described, the advice I have to offer has more or less been presented, so let that suffice.

EIGHTH EPISTLE Plato to the relatives and associates of Dion: may ye fare well

352b

I shall attempt to explain to you, as best I can, what principles you should keep in mind if you really are to fare well. Now that the tyranny has been undone, your entire struggle throughout all of Sicily involves two factions, one side wishing to restore the regime again, the other wishing to finalise the elimination of the tyranny. Now, most people in such situations think the correct advice about such matters is to recommend whatever will do most harm to your enemies and most good to your friends. But it is not at all easy while doing much harm to others to avoid suffering a lot of other evils yourself.

353a

Let this then be a prayer in all respects. Now, and ever since the war began, yourselves and your enemies have been ruled throughout, more or less, by a single family which your ancestors once appointed in their hour of utmost need, at a time when there was an extreme threat to Greek Sicily of being entirely overrun by the Carthaginians. For they then chose Dionysius, who was young and warlike, for the military activities that suited him, and Hipparinus as his senior adviser. For the safety of Sicily, these two were appointed as sole rulers, or, in other words, as tyrants.

353d

Now, it is perhaps only right that those who were saved should all be grateful after such achievements as these. But now both sides need to bear in mind just how often you have both presumed, with high expectations, that something minor was all that was needed in order to achieve your objectives. But note that this minor detail proves again and again to be the cause of countless evils. No limit is ever reached. The conclusion of a past issue always seems to be linked to the beginning of a new one, and because of this cycle there is a danger that the entire class of tyrannical folk, and democratic folk too, will be destroyed. It therefore behoves all Greeks, with all eagerness, to come up with a remedy for these evils.

354a

I shall now try to set out for you my own present views, in all frankness, based on our shared concept of justice. For I am speaking as a sort of arbitrator conversing with the two parties, the former tyrant and the subjects of the tyrant. Now, my word of advice to any tyrant would be to avoid this title and this role, and to transform tyranny into kingship if possible. And it is possible, as Lycurgus²¹, that wise and good man, has proved in practice. As a remedy, he introduced the authority of the Elders and of the Ephors as a bond to preserve the kingship. As a result, he brought security and fame to his own people, because for those people the rule of law became king, and people did not exercise tyrannical power over the laws.

354c

These are my words of exhortation to you all now. Those who are intent upon tyrannical power should turn back from what mindless folk crave so greedily and count as happiness. I would advise those who are pursuing the ways of freedom to be careful never to fall foul of the disease of their forefathers, a greedy and immoderate freedom. For before Dionysius and Hipparinus came to power, the Sicilians of that age thought they were living a happy life and even stoned to death the ten generals who preceded Dionysius, so that they would be slaves to none, subject neither to justice nor law, entirely free in every respect. Consequently, they got the tyrants, for slavery and freedom in excess are in both cases utterly evil, whereas in due measure they are entirely good.

355b

Since this is the natural state of affairs, I call upon the friends of Dion to pass on to all Syracusans the advice I have given, advice common to myself and Dion. And I shall put into words what he would have said to you were he alive and able to speak. The answer is as follows: "O Syracusans, accept, first of all, such laws as would obviously not turn your thoughts and desires towards

moneymaking and wealth. Rather, since there are these three things, soul, body and wealth, assign the greatest honour to the excellence of the soul, second greatest to that of the body, and assign the third and last place of honour to wealth, the servant of body and soul. If you come to experience what is now being said about the laws, you will know in practice that my exhortations are true.”

355d

“Accepting such laws as these, since Sicily is in a precarious situation and your side is neither sufficiently dominant nor entirely defeated, it would surely be just and advantageous for you all to adopt a middle course. These are people whose forefathers once performed the great feat of saving the Greeks from the non-Greeks, so that today we are allowed to have this discussion about political systems. So now, let one side have their freedom along with kingly rule, while the other has responsible kingly rule where the laws are master of the citizens in general, and of the kings themselves, in case they do anything contrary to the law.”

355e

“Under all these conditions, honest and sound in your thinking, with the help of the gods you should appoint three kings: my own son being the first because of a twofold debt of gratitude you owe, firstly to my father who in former times freed the city from the non-Greeks, and secondly to myself, who, of late, twice delivered you from the tyrants; then, as a second king, because of his present assistance and because of the piety of his character, appoint the man who is the son of Dionysius and bears the same name as my father, who, despite having a tyrant as a father, is of his own free will in the process of liberating the city; the third person whom you should call upon to become king is the man who is now leading the army of your adversaries, Dionysius the son of Dionysius, provided he is prepared, voluntarily, to transform himself into the shape of a

king out of fear of misfortune, or out of pity for his fatherland.”

356c

“This is what I had in mind for you while I was alive, and still have now. Having defeated our enemies at the time with your assistance, I would have established the political system in the way I had in mind had not alien demonic forces prevented me. After this, had events unfolded as I intended, I would have recolonised the rest of Sicily by depriving the non-Greeks of the territory they now hold. And I now advise all of you together to hold these same precepts, act upon them, exhort everyone to this course of action, and regard anyone who refuses as a common enemy.” But having given honours, accompanied by prayers, to all the gods, never desist from gently persuading and exhorting friends and foes in any way you can, until the words we are now speaking shall, like a divine dream presented to waking eyes, be worked out in clear, full and happy completion by yourselves.

NINTH EPISTLE Plato to Archytas of Tarentum: may you do well

357e

Archippus and Philonides and their associates have arrived, bringing us the letter you gave them and reporting the news from yourself. They concluded their dealings with the city quite easily, since these were not particularly troublesome. They then told us your news and explained that you are losing patience over your inability to get free of the busyness of public affairs. Now, it is more or less obvious to everyone that the greatest pleasure in life consists in attending to your own affairs, especially if someone chooses to deal with the sort of affairs you deal with. But you should also ponder the fact that none of us has been born for ourselves alone. Rather, our fatherland confers part of what we become, our parents another part, our

remaining loved ones another, and much comes from the circumstances that overtake us in life. And when our fatherland itself summons us to public affairs, it would surely be improper to disobey. So much for these matters. We are now looking after Echecrates, and will continue to do so hereafter for your sake, for the sake of his father, Phrynion, and for the sake of the young man himself.

TENTH EPISTLE Plato to Aristodorus: may you do well

358c

I hear that you are one of Dion's most faithful companions at present, and have been so throughout, which is the wisest characteristic of those who apply themselves to philosophy. For I maintain that true philosophy is steadfastness, loyalty and honesty, while other forms of wisdom and cleverness, tending as they do in other directions, are what I refer to, correctly I believe, as platitudes. So, remain strong and continue in the qualities in which you are now abiding.

ELEVENTH EPISTLE Plato to Laodamas: may you do well

358d

I wrote to you previously that it is most important for all the matters you speak of, that you yourself come to Athens. But since you maintain that this is impossible, the second best course, as you said in your letter, is that myself or young Socrates come to you, if possible. At the moment though, Socrates is sick with strangury, and it would be unseemly for me to go there and not accomplish what you asked of me. Besides, at my age I am not physically up to the task of travelling and running the sort of risks that are encountered by land and by sea. I can, however, give advice to yourself and the colonists,

which may, to quote Hesiod, “sound commonplace, while being hard to understand.” Now, they are mistaken in their thinking if they believe that it is ever possible for a political system to be well established by instituting laws of any sort without there being some authority looking after the day-to-day life of the city to ensure that it is both sound-minded and vigorous in the case of slaves and free alike. Until then you should set your hearts on these outcomes, keep in mind what I am saying about them, and don’t be so foolish as to think you will definitely accomplish anything. May good fortune be yours.

TWELFTH EPISTLE Plato to Archytas of Tarentum:
may you do well

359d

We received the treatises that came from you with wondrous delight, and we had particular admiration for the man who wrote them, whom we deemed worthy of those ancient ancestors of his. In fact, your people were said to have been Myrions who were among the Trojans who left during the reign of Laomedon, good men as the traditional story declares. As for my own treatises about which you wrote, they are not yet fully complete, but I have sent them to you in their present state. And since we both agree that they are to be kept safe, there is no need for me to make that request.

THIRTEENTH EPISTLE Plato to Dionysius, tyrant of
Syracuse: may you do well

360a

[Note: the best manuscripts record that this letter is not by Plato] Let this greeting mark the beginning of my letter, and at the same time be a sign that it is from me. Once, when you were entertaining the Locrian youths and were seated some distance from me, you got up, came over to me, and in a friendly way

addressed some admirable words to me, so I thought, and so too did the person beside me, who then said, “Presumably, Dionysius, when it comes to wisdom, Plato here has been of great benefit to you.” And you replied, “And in many other respects too, since from the very moment I issued the invitation, because of the fact that I sent for him, I derived immediate benefit.” Now, this is the spirit we must preserve so that our mutual benefit from one another may continually increase, and to bring this about I am now sending you some Pythagorean writings, and some ‘Divisions’, and also a man who could prove useful to yourself and Archytas. The man’s name is Helicon, and his people are from Cyzicus²⁵. He is a student of Eudoxus, and is well versed in everything that man knows. And, unusually for such people, he is not devoid of social charm, nor it seems is he of bad character; rather, on the contrary, he seems to have a light touch and to be of good character.

361a

As for the items you wrote to me to send to you, I have had the Apollo made and Leptines is bringing it to you. It is by a good, young craftsman whose name is Leochares. I thought that another work of his was most charming, so I bought it, intending to give it to your wife because she looked after me in sickness and in health in a manner that was worthy of you and me. Please give it to her unless you think otherwise. I am also sending twelve jars of sweet wine for the children, and two jars of honey. We arrived too late to store the figs, and the stored myrtle berries had rotted. We shall look after them better in future. Leptines will tell you about the plants.

361c

The money for these items, for these and for some taxes due to the city, I obtained from Leptines. Now, my own circumstances are that I have charge of four daughters of the nieces of mine who died on that occasion when you bade me wear a wreath and I would not do so. The eldest is of marriageable age, another

is eight years old, another is just over three, and the youngest is not yet one. These must be provided with dowries, by myself and by my friends, for those whom I live to see married. The eldest is to marry Speusippus⁷. She is the daughter of his sister, and she requires a dowry of no more than thirty minae, which is quite reasonable with us. And furthermore, if my own mother should pass away, no more than ten minae would be required for the construction of her tomb.

362a

The next issue I address is the expenditure of your funds at Athens. Firstly, if I am required to incur some expense in funding a chorus or something of that sort, you do not have, as we had hoped, a single friend who will advance you the money. I actually discovered this for myself when I sent Erastus to Andromides of Aegina, from whom you told me to borrow if I needed anything. But Andromides replied, reasonably and understandably, that on a previous occasion, having expended funds on your father's behalf, he had difficulty in recovering them, so he would now provide a small sum and no more. Those who ever report to you are reluctant to report anything that involves a financial expense, for fear of your displeasure. So you should get them accustomed to this and compel them to speak of these matters and of others too.

362c

I should speak of Dion next. I cannot yet speak to him of the other matters until the letters from you arrive, as promised. But in general, I think Dion is reasonably disposed towards you in word and deed. To Cratinus, the brother of Timotheus, and my friend, let us give an armoured breastplate, one of the softer variety for foot soldiers, and to the daughters of Cebes, three seven-cubit robes of Sicilian linen. You probably recognise Cebes' name since he has been written of in the Socratic dialogues, conversing with Socrates along with Simmias in the dialogue about the soul. The man is a kind friend to us all.

362e

Now, I presume you remember what I said about the sign, indicating which of my letters are written seriously and which are not. A serious letter begins with “God”, a less serious one with “gods.” The ambassadors asked me to write to you with good reason, for they sing your praises and mine with great eagerness everywhere they go. If you are sending the breastplate or anything else I wrote to you about, please give it to Terillus if you don’t have someone whom you yourself prefer. He makes the journey regularly, he is a friend of ours, and he is accomplished in philosophy and other subjects. Farewell, love wisdom, and encourage the rest of the young accordingly. Don’t neglect now the repayment of the money you owe to Leptines. Repay him as soon as possible so that others, seeing this, may be more eager to be of service to us. Iatrocles, whom I set free at the time, along with Myronidus, is now travelling with the items I am sending. Please give him some paid employment as he is well disposed towards you, and use him for whatever you wish, and preserve this letter, either the letter itself or a reminder of its contents, and be the same.

NOTES

1. Plato's authorship of the Epistles or Letters is doubted in varying degrees and there is a lack of scholarly unanimity as to whether or not any of them are by Plato. The Seventh Epistle is the one that has traditionally been least suspected, though even the authorship of this Epistle is a matter of dispute among scholars.
2. Euripides, Fragment 956.
3. Archedemus was a prominent figure in Plato's interactions with Dionysius, and, as such, is a recurring figure in the Epistles. Third Epistle 318e; Seventh Epistle 339a, 349d.
4. Hiero I was a Syracusan tyrant; Pausanias was a Spartan general and ruler who defeated the Persian Empire at Plataea. Both were associated with the poet Simonides.
5. These are groupings of famous rulers with influential thinkers. Periander was a tyrant in Corinth; Thales was a natural philosopher from Miletus; Pericles was an Athenian general and statesman; Anaxagoras was a philosopher from Clazomenae; Cyrus II was the founder of the Persian (Achaemenid) Empire; Croesus was a king of Lydia, and Solon was an Athenian statesman and legislator.
6. Phylition was a physician and thinker from Locri in southern Italy.
7. Speusippus was Plato's nephew, who became head of the Academy after Plato's death.
8. Perdiccas III was a ruler of Macedon.
9. Euphraeus of Oreus was a student of Plato who rose to prominence in Macedon under the rule of Perdiccas III.
10. Hermias, Erastus and Coriscus were all members of Plato's Academy. Hermias became a tyrant in Atarneus and was the father-in-law of Aristotle. Erastus and Coriscus were brothers from Scepsis. Both Atarneus and Scepsis were in Ionia.
11. Although Plato's authorship of the Seventh Epistle is often doubted, there are scholars who regard it as authentic.
12. These were the supporters of the democracy. The incident is recounted in Plato's Apology.
13. This is Dionysius II, the son of Dionysius I, tyrant of Syracuse, whose death is described just above.

14. This actually describes Plato's second time in Sicily, but is his first interaction with Dionysius II.
15. Archytas of Tarentum was a Pythagorean philosopher and mathematician. He was also a prominent statesman in his native city in southern Italy. He was an important associate of Plato and is mentioned in several of Plato's epistles, some of which are addressed to him.
16. A proverbial expression ('the third to the saviour').
17. Lynceus journeyed with the Argonauts and served as the lookout for them.
18. Iliad vii.360.
19. Odyssey xii.428, Lattimore.
20. The Phoenicians and Opici were two ancient peoples. The former originated in modern-day Lebanon but had established colonies in Sicily. The latter occupied the Campania region in modern-day Italy.
21. Lycurgus was a Spartan legislator.
22. This is the young Socrates who appears as an interlocutor with the Eleatic Stranger in Plato's *Statesman*.
23. This comment about the Thirteenth Epistle comes from the best-attested manuscripts and may go back to Thrasyllus, one of the early editors of Plato's work.
24. The greeting 'may you do well' is intended as an indication of authorship due to its frequent use. Third Epistle 315a-b.
25. Eudoxus of Cnidus was an astronomer and mathematician who had studied with Archytas and Plato. He eventually moved his school from Cyzicus to Athens, and merged it with the Academy.
26. Isocrates was an influential Athenian rhetorician and teacher of rhetoric.
27. Bryson of Heraclea was a mathematician and sophist who is thought to have studied with Socrates. The ancient historian Theopompus claims that Plato had taken many ideas for his dialogues from Bryson.
28. This is a reference to the King of the Persian Empire.

Epinomis

ΕΠΙΝΟΜΙΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

ATHENIAN STRANGER

CLINIAS of Cnossus, Crete

MEGILLUS of Sparta

scene: no setting

973a

Clinias: Well, stranger, here we are, duly assembled, all three of us as we agreed, you and me and Megillus here, to consider what account we should give of the sort of understanding which, according to us, once apprehended, gives a person the finest understanding a human being can possibly have. For although we maintain that we have, in general, described all matters concerned with lawgiving, we have neither investigated nor referred to the most important question: what exactly should a mere mortal learn in order to become wise? So we should now attempt to make good this omission. Indeed, we run the risk of failing to complete the objective of all our endeavours, which was to clarify everything from beginning to end.

973b

Athenian: Well said, Clinias. I believe the argument you're about to hear is unusual, and also, in a sense, not so strange at all. Indeed, many people, based upon their experience of life, proffer the same argument – that humankind will never be blessed or happy. Follow me, then, and decide whether or not you think I am right in what I say, along with them, about such a matter. I deny the possibility of humanity, with few exceptions, being blessed and happy, at least during this lifetime. But on dying, there is a noble hope of encountering everything that we are so eager for, as we live the very best life we can whilst alive, and we aim for the noblest departure when we die. I am not saying anything wise, but something that all Greeks and non-Greeks would somehow recognise: that from the very

outset, being born is a difficulty for every creature. First, there is involvement in the condition of all who dwell in the womb, then there is the actual birth, followed by nurture and education, and everyone agrees that all of these give rise to a great deal of trouble. And, indeed, if we don't count the travails but only what people would regard as acceptable, the duration would be quite short, providing a sort of breathing space, it seems, in the middle phase of human life. But old age sets in quickly, making anyone who is not full of naïve notions reluctant to live life all over again, having reflected upon the life that has just been lived.

974b

Athenian: So, what evidence do I have for all this? This is the nature of the subject of our current investigation. We are investigating the manner in which we may become wise on the assumption that each of us has this capacity in some measure. But it takes flight and is gone once someone embarks upon any understanding of the so-called skills or the other areas of understanding or branches of knowledge, as none of these deserves the title of wisdom concerning these human affairs. But our soul is strongly convinced and intuits that it somehow possesses this wisdom by nature, although it is quite unable to find out when and how, or even to discover what it is. Now, doesn't the problem with our enquiry into wisdom bear a strong resemblance to this? Shall we agree that this is how matters stand, or not?

974c

Clinias: We shall agree, stranger, based perhaps on the hope that, in your company, in due course, the truest possible opinion on these matters may eventually arise.

Athenian: Well, we must first review the other kinds of knowledge, so-called, whose acquisition does not render the possessor wise. Well, in the first place, of those which constitute

the primary needs of the mortal race we should note that, although these branches of knowledge are more or less the most necessary of all, their possessor is certainly not regarded as wise nowadays. And since it is not by our skill, it seems, but by nature subject to God that we have all come to manage the earth, agriculture will never really make us wise either. Nor indeed will the building of houses, or construction in general, the manufacture of various sorts of equipment, the work of the blacksmith, the carpenter, the potter, the weaver, and the provision of all sorts of tools. This knowledge is of benefit to the populace, but it is not said to confer excellence. Nor again does hunting in all its forms ever elevate the soul and confer wisdom; neither does prophecy or its interpretation do so at all, for the prophet merely knows what he is saying without understanding whether it is true or not.

975b

Athenian: Now, we can see that the acquisition of our necessities is achieved by means of skill, but that none of the skills makes a person wise; what is left after this is play, which is, for the most part, imitative, but by no means serious. For although they are engaging in imitation by various devices, and by numerous imitations of the body itself that are most unseemly, and by means of words and music in general, and the arts that are born of painting, achieving a great variety of designs of all sorts in various media, imitation does not make anyone wise in any respect, even someone who toils with the utmost diligence.

975c

Athenian: When these have all been excluded, what remains is defence of vast numbers of people by countless means, the most important and extensive being called military skill, the skill of the general, requiring a lot of good fortune, but, by nature, given more to courage than to wisdom. As for the skill of the physician, this is presumably a defence of sorts against the

ravages inflicted upon the nature of living creatures by the various seasons with their untimely cold and heat and the like. But none of this is reputed to be wisdom in the truest sense, being devoid of measure and driven by opinion and guesswork. We also refer to steersmen, and sailors too, as defenders, but you would not declare a single man among them to be wise. Those who claim to act as our defenders in lawsuits with their power of speech pay attention to human character by means of memory and experience born of opinion, but they have strayed far from the truth of what is really just.

976c

Athenian: But there remains yet an unusual power that is reputed to be wisdom, although most people would call it a natural capacity rather than wisdom. It is noticed in a person who easily learns whatever he is learning, securely commits a lot of material to memory, recalls what is relevant to each situation and what is appropriate, and quickly enacts this. All this is designated by some as a natural capacity, by others as wisdom, by others as a natural shrewdness, but no sensible person will ever be prepared to call someone truly wise for any of these endowments.

976d

Athenian: But surely there must prove to be some knowledge whose possession would constitute the wisdom of the one who is truly wise and does not merely seem so. Let's see. For we are attempting to find, through an extremely difficult argument, another knowledge besides those we have mentioned, a knowledge which may truly and reasonably be described as wisdom, which will render its possessor neither lowly nor simple-minded, by which he will be a wise and good denizen of the city, ruling and being ruled justly, as a fitting citizen. So, let's first look for the one knowledge among all those we have at present, which would render the human race mindless and stupid if it were removed from human nature. There is not

much difficulty in seeing what this is. For comparing one with another, so to speak, the knowledge which gives number to the entire mortal race would do this. And it is a god, I believe, rather than good fortune, that saves us by giving this to us.

977a

Athenian: But I believe I should state which god, since it is an unusual one, and somehow, again, not unusual. For how could we ever doubt that the cause of everything that is good for us is also the cause of the greatest good of all, namely understanding? So, Megillus and Clinias, what god am I referring to with such seriousness? Surely it is Uranus whom we are duty bound to honor along with all the other daimons and gods, and to whom above all we should pray. We would all agree that he has been the cause of everything else that is good for us, and we also maintain, correctly, that he has at the same time also given us number, and continues to give this to anyone who is willing to follow along. For once someone embarks upon the correct contemplation of this god, either as the universe, as Olympus or as the heaven, or whatever one pleases to call it, let him only follow how this provides the seasons and sustenance to all as it variegates itself and turns all the courses of the stars within itself. But if someone, having accepted his gift of numbers were to explore the entire circuit of the heaven, this would be the supreme benefit.

977c

Athenian: Yet, going back a little in the argument, we should recall how right we were to appreciate that if number was indeed removed from human nature, we would never attain any understanding. For the soul of that creature from whom rational discourse is absent could never yet attain total excellence. And a creature that could recognise neither two nor three, odd nor even, and was ignorant of number in general, would never be able to give a rational account of anything of which it had acquired mere sense impressions and memories.

There is, however, nothing to prevent it from acquiring the rest of excellence, courage and sound-mindedness. But being deprived of true discourse, no one could ever become wise, and whoever is devoid of wisdom, the greatest part of excellence as a whole, could never become happy because he would not have become perfectly good. And so, it is absolutely necessary that number be the foundation, and not a single skill we mentioned earlier remains once someone does away with the skill of number.

977e

Athenian: Someone, having considered the various skills, might perhaps assume that the human race needs number for everyday purposes, although even this is important. But what if someone were to behold both the divine and the mortal aspects of creation, in which reverence and true number will be discovered? Indeed, music in all its aspects obviously requires the enumeration of movements and sounds. And anyone who is to conclude his life in happiness needs to appreciate that any, more or less, irrational, disordered, unseemly, unrhythmical and inharmonious motion, and anything else that involves anything bad, is lacking in all number.

978a

Athenian: Let us proceed, then, with our enquiry into this very question: how did we learn to use number? Come on then, from where did the one and the two come to us? Now, in many other creatures, the nature enabling them to do this is not even present, and so they are unable to learn how to use number even from the Father. But God first implanted this particular ability in us so that we would be up to the task of understanding what is being shown, and he then showed us, and continues to do so. Of all that is shown to us, what one could be a more beautiful one than the realm of day? We may then come to the night time retaining our vision, where something totally different from it would be presented to us. And as the heaven

keeps on revolving these very objects around, through many nights and many days, it keeps on teaching one and two to us humans until even the slowest learner has adequately learned how to use number.

978b

Athenian: And, indeed, on seeing these, each of us would also conceive of three and four and many. And as he was fashioning the various objects, God made one of them, the moon, which appears large at one time, smaller at another, as it proceeds on its way, always illuminating a different day, until fifteen days and nights have elapsed. This is its actual orbit if you are prepared to treat a single whole cycle as one, so that even a creature who is very slow to learn would learn this. God, having made the waxing and waning moon, as we have said, also established, in conjunction, the months in relation to the year. And so, as a happy outcome, all creatures began to discern number in relation to number. Through these, the earth brings forth its fruits and harvests for us in order to provide nourishment for all living things, as the winds and rains arise without excess in due measure. But if anything occurs for the worse, contrary to these measures, the divine nature should not be held responsible.

979c

Athenian: Now, in our enquiry into laws, it seemed to be easy, in general, to understand what is best for humanity. It seemed then, and still seems now, that all the other pursuits are not particularly difficult, but the question of how we are to become good people is extremely difficult. And everyone agrees with everyone else that the soul should be good, and about the way in which it should be good. It should be just, sound-minded and courageous, and everyone maintains that it should be wise too, but as to the sort of wisdom, as we have already explained, no one agrees at all with anyone else in most cases. Now, however, we are discovering, besides all the previous wisdoms, another

one which is not without its uses for certain purposes: whoever has learned the subjects we have outlined seems to be wise. But whether the person who is knowledgeable in these subjects is indeed wise and good, is a question that needs to be decided.

979e

Clinias: How right you were, stranger, to say that we are trying to come up with important formulations on important issues.

Athenian: Indeed, Clinias, the issues are not trivial, but the greater difficulty is that the formulations are to be completely true in every way.

Clinias: Very much so, stranger, but you should not tire of saying what you are saying.

Athenian: Yes, and you two are to keep on listening.

Clinias: Granted. I am answering on behalf of both of us.

980a

Athenian: Very well. To begin with then, we need to say, first and foremost, it appears, most of all, whether or not we are able to capture in a single word what we think wisdom is. But if this proves quite impossible for us, we should say, secondly, what, and what kinds of wisdom, would, according to our account, make a person wise, if he were to acquire them.

Clinias: Please proceed.

Athenian: After this, no reproach will ever be incurred by the lawgiver for presenting a likeness of the gods that is nobler and better than any that have been presented previously, having recourse to a sort of noble game, honouring the gods and celebrating them with hymns and happiness throughout his own life.

980b

Clinias: Well said, stranger. Let this indeed be the objective of your laws: that the life be lived in greater purity, praising the

gods, and that it may end in nobility and supreme goodness.

Athenian: So, Clinias, how are we to describe this? Do you think we should honour the gods by singing heartfelt hymns, praying that the noblest and best words will come to us? Is this the way? Or what do you think?

980c

Clinias: Yes, that's a wonderful way to proceed. So, good man, have faith in the gods, utter your prayers, and then speak the beautiful words that come to you about the gods and goddesses.

Athenian: It shall be so provided if the god himself guides us. Just join in the prayer.

Clinias: Speak on.

Athenian: Well firstly, since our predecessors did such a bad job of describing the origin of gods and mortal creatures, it is necessary for me first to express this better, based upon my previous argument, resuming what I was trying to say to the impious folk. I was saying that there are gods who care for all things great and small, and who are more or less incapable of persuasion in matters of justice. The most important of these statements was that any soul would be elder than any body. This must surely be the case, for it is plausible that the better, more ancient and more godlike be elder than the young, the younger and the less honourable, and that the ruler be elder in every respect than the ruled, and the leader than the led. Let us understand, then, that soul is elder than body. But if this is the case, our starting point would constitute a more plausible basis for the starting point of creation, and we could then propose that we are embarking aright upon the greatest wisdom, that which concerns the origin of gods.

981a

Clinias: Let it be so. We have spoken as best we can.

Athenian: Come on, then. Should we declare that a living creature may most truly be described, according to its nature, as a combination of soul and body coming together to give rise to a single form?

Clinias: Correct.

Athenian: Is something of this sort then rightly called a living creature?

Clinias: Yes.

981b

Athenian: Well, according to the likely account, we should say that there are five solid bodies from which the best and most exalted things may be moulded, while the other kind, in its entirety, has a single form. For nothing could be bodiless and always entirely devoid of colour, apart from the truly most divine kind, which is soul. To this alone, we may say, belongs the function of moulding and fashioning. Now, we should declare that there is fire and water, that air is third, earth fourth, and ether fifth, and that every creature is perfected in complexity and variety by the relative predominance of these bodies. We should propose that the first one is earthy, consisting of all humans, all creatures with many feet, those without feet, those that are mobile, and those that are immobile, being held fast by their roots. We should also propose that there is another type of living creature that consists mostly of fire. And so we should declare that various living creatures, also visible, arise from these constituents, and we should think of them as the race of the creatures of the heavens, which, we should declare, constitute collectively the divine race of stars, each possessed of a perfect body and the happiest and very best soul.

981e

Athenian: So let us, in the first place, bear in mind that, according to us, there are two living beings of this sort: both are visible, although one seems to be composed wholly of fire, the other of earth. The earthy one moves in a disorderly manner, while the one composed of fire moves in perfect order. The one that moves in a disorderly manner should be thought of as unintelligent, acting for the most part like the living creatures about us. The one that maintains an orderly course in heaven should provide us with great evidence of being intelligent. Indeed, by constantly proceeding, acting, and being acted upon in the same way without variation, it would be providing sufficient evidence of living in an intelligent way.

982c

Athenian: Soul has made the best decision in accord with supreme reason, the result is unalterable and complete, truly in accord with reason, and not even adamant could ever prove stronger or more unalterable than this. But, in fact, three Fates hold fast and keep watch to ensure the completion of whatever has been decided with perfect deliberation by any of the gods. For humanity, there should have been adequate proof that the stars and their entire proceedings are possessed of reason in the fact that they always do the same things because they are acting out deliberations of ancient date, made a wondrously long time ago. This conclusion of ours is the very opposite of what most people believe. They think that whatever does the same things without variation does not possess soul. Hence, most people assume that humans are intelligent and alive because they are moving, while the divine race is unintelligent because its orbits remain the same. But humanity could have relied upon the more beautiful, the better, the friendly to understand that whatever is the same and unvarying and always acts accordingly should, for this very reason, be regarded as intelligent. Such is the nature of the stars, most beautiful to behold, as they dance the most beautiful and exalted dance

movement of all.

983a

Athenian: And, indeed, to justify our claim that they have souls, we should first consider their size. For they are not small as they appear to be; each of them is, rather, of enormous bulk. Indeed, it is possible to appreciate correctly that the sun as a whole is larger than the entire earth, and that all the moving stars are possessed of wondrous magnitude. Well, I maintain that God will be the cause of their revolutions, otherwise this is not possible at all. For as we have shown, nothing could ever become ensouled except through God. It is not possible that earth and the heaven, all of the stars and the complete masses formed from them, should proceed with such precision by the year, the month and the day, and that all these happenings benefit all of us, without soul being present to each, or, indeed, in each of them.

983d

Athenian: Insofar as a human being is debased, it is necessary that he avoid mere blabbering and prove to be speaking sensibly. Now, anyone who speaks of the surges or natures of bodies as causes will not be talking sense. Firstly, there are two things, body and soul, and there are many instances of each; there is no third thing common to both, and, finally, soul is distinct from body. We shall propose that one is presumably intelligent, the other devoid of intelligence, one rules while the other is ruled, one is the cause of all while the other is not the cause of any effect. And so, it is most foolish and unreasonable to maintain that whatever is in the heaven has come into being by some other agency, and is not the product of soul and body as we say it is. Now, if our arguments about everything of this sort are to prevail, one or the other of two things must be said of them: either they are to be glorified as actual gods, or they are to be understood as images of gods, created representations, fashioned by the gods themselves.

984b

Athenian: Now, in relation to gods, we should undertake this much: having discerned two kinds of creature, both visible – one, we maintain, being immortal, the other, the earthy, being mortal – we should attempt to speak of the three that are in between these two, the middle three of the five, doing so with the utmost clarity based upon reasoned opinion. Indeed, we should place ether above fire and propose that soul fashions, from this, living creatures possessing power belonging for the most part to the nature of ether. After ether, we should propose that soul fashions a different kind of creature from air, and a third from water. And soul, having wrought all these, is likely to have filled the entire heaven full of living creatures using all five kinds according to their power, all having come into being partaking of life. These are second, third, fourth and fifth in descent from the manifest gods, ending with us humans.

984c

Athenian: As for the gods such as Zeus, Hera and all the others, anyone may propose whatever they wish, but in accordance with the same convention. The visible gods, then, the greatest, the most honoured, the keenest of sight, must be said to be first. These are the stars and whatever else we observe among their cohort. After these and below these in order are the daimons, the airy type, occupying the third and middle position, responsible for interpretation, whom we should greatly honour in our prayers to ensure that they convey auspicious messages. Partaking of a wondrous intelligence, since they constitute a race that learns and remembers with ease, we should declare that they are aware of the entire content of our minds, take delight in the noble and good, and hate the utterly ignoble since they do share in the experience of pain. And the heaven has been filled full of living creatures, who all interpret towards one another and towards all the supreme gods.

985d

Athenian: Now, since there are indeed these five living creatures, howsoever any of us have encountered them, coming across them in dreams whilst asleep, in prophetic statements and utterances heard in health or in disease, or meeting with them at the end of our lives, beliefs develop in individuals or in communities from which various sacred traditions of many peoples have arisen and will arise. And no lawgiver possessed of reason would ever dare to engage in innovation in any of these, and turn his own city over to some service of God that is insecure. Vile indeed are those who dare not speak of them and reveal that there are these other gods, bereft of rituals, receiving not the honours that are due to them. Wouldn't it be agreed then by the man himself, or anyone who understood the situation, that he might rightly be referred to as a bad man?

986a

Clinias: Of course, stranger, the worst of men.

Athenian: Well then, dear Clinias, mark my words, this is clearly what I am engaged in now.

Clinias: How so?

Athenian: Note that there are, in the entire heaven, eight powers that are kindred to one another. These I have observed, and this is no great achievement; in fact, it is easy for anyone. Three of these belong, in one case, to the sun, in another to the moon, and to the stars we mentioned a little earlier. There are five others. But let no one of us ever believe, idly, that some of these are gods while others are not. Instead, we should all declare and proclaim that these are all kindred and share kindred destinies. Happy is the man who, in the first place, wonders at all this and then develops a passion for understanding as much about this as our mortal nature will allow, deeming this to be the best and most fortunate way to spend his life, and attain after death the regions where excellence abides. Then, having been initiated into truth and

reality, being one himself and possessed of one understanding, he will thereafter have a perfect vision of all that is most beautiful, as far as sight allows.

986e

Athenian: What remains for us is to say what and how many of these beings there are, for we should never prove false. I affirm then, with certainty, this much at least: there are eight orbits, three of which have been described already while five still remain. The fourth motion or circuit, together with the fifth, travels at more or less the same speed as the sun, and, in general, neither slower nor faster. Let us say that these are the orbits of the sun, the dawn-bearer, and a third whose name we cannot utter because it is unknown, the reason being that the person who first observed these was a non-Greek.

987a

Athenian: An ancient circumstance encouraged the first observers. Because Egypt and Syria are blessed with an excellent summer season, they had a more or less continuous view of all the stars, since clouds and rains are consistently absent from that part of the world. And so their observations, well tested over a vast, nay limitless, period of time, have spread abroad and arrived here. Therefore, we must be courageous enough to pass laws for these, since it obviously makes no sense that some divinities are honoured while others are not. For the dawn-bearer, which is the same as the evening star, is, by common account, the star of Aphrodite, and this is a most appropriate name for a Syrian convention setter to assign. That which runs its course more or less along with this, and with the sun too, is the star of Hermes. We should also mention three further orbits of bodies proceeding to the right along with the moon and the sun. And we should also mention one, the eighth, which may especially be referred to as the Cosmos, proceeding in the opposite direction to all those, leading the others.

987d

Athenian: The actual truth seems somehow to lie in this direction. Three stars remain, one of which is much slower than the others, and some people take this to be the star of Cronus; the next slowest should be called the star of Zeus, and after this comes the star of Ares, which has the reddest colour of all. None of these phenomena are difficult to apprehend once someone has described them, but it is necessary for someone who has understood the matter to take the lead.

987e

Athenian: Now, there is something that every Greek should understand: the region we Greeks inhabit is perhaps the best of all for the acquisition of human excellence. And in praise of this, it should be explained that our climate is a mean between the extremes of winter and summer. Although such matters as these are difficult to investigate with certainty, there is, nevertheless, a great and noble expectation that we Greeks will exercise a better and, indeed, a more just concern for all these gods than the tradition and worship that has come from the non-Greeks. For we will make use of instruction and prophecy that comes from Delphi, and the entire system of worship ordained by our laws. And let none of us Greeks ever harbour the fear that mere mortals must refrain from engagement with matters divine. We should hold the very opposite view: that the divine is never devoid of intelligence, nor somehow ignorant of our human nature.

988c

Athenian: Now, there is an account, widespread and plausible, that there was a time when humans had their initial conceptions of the gods and how they came into being, and the sort of beings they were and how they engaged in various activities. But the accounts were neither acceptable to nor to the liking of the sound-minded. Nor could they accept the subsequent accounts in which priority was attributed to fire and water and other bodies, and lower status given to the

wondrous soul. But now, since we are saying that soul, once it has actually come to be present in the body, naturally moves and circulates both itself and the body, it is no wonder that soul is the cause of all circulation and motion, that the circulation and motion towards the good belongs to the best soul, while the opposite holds for the opposite kind of soul, and anything that is good must prevail, now and ever, over its opposite.

989a

Athenian: We have said all this according to justice, the avenger of those who are unholy. But, regarding the matter under scrutiny, we cannot but believe that we should regard the good as wise. As for the wisdom we have sought for so long, we should see whether we can discern this in some education or skill whose lack of recognition among the just would render us ignorant for being like this.

989b

Athenian: Indeed, I am strongly of the view, as indicated by what has just been said, that our failures in practising the most important part of excellence is responsible for our predicament. And it must be said that for our mortal race there is no part of excellence more important than reverence, and we should never be persuaded to the contrary. But through the utmost ignorance, this reverence has not arisen in the very best natures. The very best natures are those that, although they come into existence only with extreme difficulty, nevertheless confer enormous benefit when they do arise. For the soul that quietly accepts its due measure of lethargy and its opposite would be good-natured, admire courage, and be easily persuaded towards sound-mindedness. And, most importantly in such natures, soul is able to learn, has a good memory and is able to delight in these qualities, and thus develop a love of learning.

989d

Athenian: For although these qualities are not easy to develop, once they have arisen and have encountered the nurture and education they need, they would be able to constrain the majority of people, the baser sort, in the right way, to think, act and speak about the gods as they should and when they should in relation to sacrifices and purifications belonging to the gods and to humans, not as a mere outward show, but truly valuing excellence, which is indeed of the utmost importance for everyone in every city. According to us, then, this part is, by nature, the most exalted and well capable of learning all that is noblest and best, provided there is a teacher. But there would be no teaching unless God were to take the lead.

989e

Athenian: Let us attempt, then, to give an account explaining what these things are, their characteristics, and how they should be learned, to the best of my ability as the speaker and your abilities as listeners. So, in what way may someone learn to serve God? Now, although it may sound strange on first hearing, we should at least state its name, a name which someone with no experience of the subject would never guess. The subject is astronomy, but people are unaware that the true astronomer must necessarily be utterly wise. He should not engage in astronomy, as did Hesiod and so many others like him, by observing risings and settings, rather than observing seven orbits of the eight as they each proceed in a way that would be beyond the capacity of most natures to discern easily. An exceptional nature would be required.

990b

Athenian: The moon traverses its orbit fastest, bringing the month and the full moon first. Next, we should observe the sun throughout its entire cycle, and those bodies that run their course along with it as it brings the solstices. Now, let's just say that the other orbits of these bodies as described previously are not easy to understand, and to produce natures that are up to

the task it is necessary to work hard and consistently at basic education and training in childhood and youth. Certain studies would therefore be required. First and foremost is that of numbers themselves, devoid of anything physical, concerned rather with the overall generation of odd and even, and the influence this has upon the nature of things that are.

990d

Athenian: Having learned this, what comes next goes by the very strange name of geometry, which, by reference to part of plane surfaces, produces a likeness of numbers that are not by nature like one another. Now, it should be evident to anyone who could understand this marvel that it is no mere human contrivance, but divine in origin. After this are numbers that multiply threefold, and are like unto the three-dimensional. Then again, those that are unlike are made like by a different skill, which those who are acquainted with it call stereometry. This is godly, and a wonder to those who look closely and appreciate that nature in its entirety, in the case of each ratio, is continually turning power, and the opposite to this, about the double. In the means between these themselves, in both senses, the benefit of consonance and symmetry is bestowed upon humanity in furtherance of the play of rhythm and harmony, a gift from the blessed chorus of the Muses.

991a

Athenian: So much, then, for all these matters, let them be as we have described them. But to bring them to a conclusion, we should proceed to a divine creation that is at once most beautiful to behold, and, indeed, the most divine production of any that God has allowed us humans to have sight of. But no one can ever claim to have understood this easily without a clear vision of everything we are now explaining. We must also grasp the precision of the timing, and how precisely all the phenomena of the heaven are completed, so that anyone who has come to believe in the truth of our argument that soul is

older than body, and more divine too, would come to the view that it is right and reasonable to declare that “everything is full of gods”, and that we will never be neglected by our superiors through their forgetfulness or inattention.

991c

Athenian: In relation to all matters of this sort, it is necessary to bear in mind that if someone grasps each of these aright, a great benefit accrues to whoever apprehends systematically. It is necessary to explain what we mean by ‘systematically’. Every geometric construction, every numerical system and harmonic⁶ structure, and the unified agreement of all the circuits of the stars, should be revealed to the person who learns systematically. And revealed they shall be if, as we say, a person learns aright by looking towards one. For a single bond naturally uniting all these will be revealed to those who think about things in this way. For without these studies, no happy person will make an appearance in our cities. This is the system, this is the upbringing, these are the subjects, and whether it be difficult or easy, this is the course along which we must proceed.

992a

Athenian: Whoever has grasped all these subjects together is deemed by me as most truly the wisest. Of such a person, I insist, in jest and in all seriousness too, that when his destiny is fulfilled in death – if we may say that he still persists after death – he will no longer partake of a multiplicity of perceptions as he does now. Having a share of one destiny alone, having become one from many, he will be happy and wise, and blessed too, and whether he lives this blessed life on continents or on certain islands, he will forever share in good fortune of this sort.

992c

Athenian: The same argument is presenting itself now, the one we stated at the very outset, and it really is true that, with few exceptions, it is not possible for us humans to be perfectly

blessed and happy. For only those who are divine and sound-minded and naturally share in excellence in general, and, furthermore, have grasped everything that is contained in the blessed subject – and we have explained what this involves – only these people adequately acquire and retain the entirety of that which belongs to the divine. And so, we maintain in private and enact in public, in our laws, that those who work at these studies in the right way should be awarded the highest positions of authority in their advanced later years. The others, speaking reverently towards all the gods and goddesses, are to follow such people, and it is only right that all of us, having properly recognised this wisdom and put it to the test, should call upon the Nocturnal Council to pursue it too.

NOTES

1. This introduces the notion of ratio.
2. This picks up on the argument from Laws x.
3. Laws x.891e ff, 896a ff.
4. Stereometry is the measurement of solids.
5. These three progressions represent the transition from one dimension to three dimensions. The values of one-dimensionality, which are based on the ratio of 1:2, are squared to obtain the values of two-dimensionality, and cubed to get the values of the 'solid and tangible' third dimension.
6. These ratios are obtained through taking the arithmetic mean, 9, and the harmonic mean, 8, between 6 and 12: $9:6 = 3:2$ and $8:6 = 4:3$; $12:8 = 3:2$ and $12:9 = 4:3$.
7. Aristotle in his *De Anima* (I.5.411a8) attributes this phrase to the pre-Socratic philosopher Thales.

Euthydemus

ΕΥΘΥΔΗΜΟΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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narrator: SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

persons in the dialogue:

CRITO *a friend and contemporary of Socrates*

CLINIAS *of Scambonidae, son of Axiochus*

EUTHYDEMUS *of Chios and Thurii, sophist*

DIONYSODORUS *brother of Euthydemus*

CTESIPPUS *of Paeania, cousin of Menexenus*

scene: the Lyceum

271a

Crito: Who was it, Socrates, you were conversing with in the Lyceum yesterday? There was such a large crowd gathered around you that even though I wanted to listen I was not able to hear anything clearly when I got close. Yet when I popped my head up I got a look, and you seemed to be in conversation with a stranger. Who was he?

Socrates: Which of them are you asking about, Crito? For there were two men, not one.

271b

Crito: I am referring to the man seated two places to your right. Axiochus' boy was between the two of you, and he seemed to me to have really grown up, Socrates, and to be much the same age as our own Critobolus, who is a slender youth, while that boy looks older than his years and is noble and good in aspect.

Socrates: Euthydemus is the man you are asking about, Crito. And the person seated on my left was his brother, Dionysodorus. He gets involved in the discussions too.

271c

Crito: I don't know either of them, Socrates. They are, it seems, more sophists, a new kind. Where are they from, and what is their wisdom?

Socrates: Although the family is, I believe, from this part of the world, from Chios, these men went to Thurii as colonists. But after being exiled from there, they have already spent several years in these regions. As for your question about their wisdom, it is astounding, Crito. These two are almost totally wise. They really are a pair of total combatants – not like the two total athletes from Acharnania. For those two are able to fight with the body alone, while these two are firstly physically formidable in armour-fighting, and able to teach anyone who pays them a fee. Secondly, they are supreme in courtroom combat, both in fighting a case, and in teaching someone else to deliver and to compose the kind of speeches appropriate for the law courts. And of late they have brought perfection to their skill as total athletes, becoming so formidable in verbal combat and in refuting whatever anyone says, whether it be true or false. So I am thinking of placing myself in their hands, Crito.

272b

Crito: What's this, Socrates? Aren't you afraid, at your age, that you may already be too old?

Socrates: Not in the least, Crito. I have enough evidence, and encouragement, not to be afraid. For these two were almost old men when they embarked in this disputatious wisdom which I am so keen on. There is only one thing I am afraid of – that I might draw criticism upon the two strangers, just as I did to the harpist Connus, who still, even now, is teaching me to play the harp. So I'm afraid someone may criticise the two strangers in the very same way. And perhaps, fearing this very outcome, they may be unwilling to accept me. Yet, Crito, I have persuaded other old men to attend the class as fellow pupils of mine, and in this case too I shall attempt to persuade some others. Yes, why don't you attend along with me? And we will bring your sons as bait. Since they will want the boys as pupils, I know that they will educate us too.

272c

Crito: There's no reason not to, Socrates, if that's what you think. But first explain to me what the wisdom of the two men is so that I may know what we are going to learn.

Socrates: You shall hear straightaway, as I can't claim that I didn't pay attention to them. No, I attended fully, and I remember, and I shall try to recount everything to you from the beginning. Indeed, by some divine providence I happened to be sitting there, just where you saw me, alone in the dressing room, and I was already thinking of getting up to leave. But as soon as I stood up, the familiar divine sign came. So I sat down again, and a little later these two men entered, Euthydemus and Dionysodorus, and others too, pupils of theirs, I think. And once they arrived they walked about in the roofed portico. They had barely completed two or three circuits when Clinias¹ came in – and what you say is true, he really has grown up. Behind him was a whole host of admirers, and among them was Ctesippus, a young man from the deme of Paeania, noble and good by nature, except for some arrogance born of youth.

272e

Socrates: Now, when Clinias saw me from the entrance, seated on my own, he came straight over and sat down on my right, just as you say. On seeing him, Dionysodorus and Euthydemus first stood talking to one another, glancing over at us from time to time. Then one of them, Euthydemus, went and sat beside the young man, while the other one sat next to me on my left, and the others sat where they could.

273a

Well, I greeted them both warmly as it was some time since I had seen them, and then I said to Clinias that Euthydemus and Dionysodorus knew everything there is to know about warfare, whatever anyone who is to be a good general needs to know, and that they are also able to make someone capable of coming to his own aid in court, should someone do him an injustice.

Now, when I said this they were contemptuous. So they laughed, exchanged glances, and Euthydemus said, “We no longer take these matters seriously, Socrates. No, we treat them as diversions.” I was amazed and I said, “Your work must surely be noble if such weighty concerns as these are mere diversions for you. By god, tell me what this noble concern is.” “Excellence, Socrates,” he replied, “is what we believe we are able to impart better and more quickly than anyone else.”

273e

“By Zeus,” I said, “you are making quite a declaration. Where did you discover this godsend? But, Dionysodorus and Euthydemus, make sure you are speaking the truth. For when you are making such an enormous proclamation, don’t be surprised if it is disbelieved.” “Well, Socrates, you may rest assured that this is how matters stand.” “Then I account you far more blessed for this possession than the Great King for his empire. But tell me this. Are you thinking of giving a demonstration of this wisdom, or what do you intend?” “That’s the very reason we are here, Socrates, to give a demonstration and to teach, if anyone wishes to learn.”

274c

I asked them then to demonstrate – not a comprehensive one, but to convince this young man here, Clinias, that he should practise philosophy and concern himself with excellence, and I described the boy’s situation: the son of Axiochus, first cousin of the present Alcibiades, young and at risk of being turned to some other pursuit. Now, once I had said almost exactly this, Euthydemus responded in a manner both courageous and confident. “That makes no difference, Socrates,” he said, “as long as the young man is willing to answer.” “Well,” I replied, “he certainly is well accustomed to this, for these people here are constantly coming to him, asking him lots of questions and engaging him in discourse, and so he is quite courageous at answering.”

275c

So Euthydemus began somewhat as follows. “Clinias, who are the people who learn? Are they the wise or the unlearned?” And the young man, faced with such a significant question, blushed and looked at me in perplexity. And once I realised that he had been upset, I said, “Take heart, Clinias. Answer courageously, giving whatever answer seems right to you, for this may well confer an enormous benefit upon you.” At this, Dionysodorus leaned forward and whispered that whatever answer the young man gives, he will be refuted. And Clinias answered that those who learn are the wise. Then Euthydemus led him through a series of steps: when you were learning, you did not yet know the things you were learning? Then you were not wise, but unlearned? “Then whilst you were learning what you did not know, you were learning whilst being unlearned – it is the unlearned who learn, Clinias, and not, as you believe, the wise.” Now, once he had said all this, his followers laughed and cheered like a chorus at a signal from their teacher.

276a

And before the youth had well and truly recovered, Dionysodorus took over. “What about this, Clinias? Whenever the grammarian gave dictation to you, which boys learned the dictation, the wise or the unlearned?” “The wise,” replied Clinias. “So it is the wise who learn, not the unlearned, and you didn’t answer Euthydemus properly just now.” With this, the admirers of the two men laughed and cheered loudly in delight at their wisdom, while the rest of us were stunned and fell silent. And Euthydemus, in order to astound us even more, like one of those good dancers, gave a double twist to his questions on the same topic and asked, “Now, do those who learn, learn what they know or what they do not know?” And Dionysodorus whispered again, “And this, Socrates, will be another one, similar to the previous one.”

277a

He put Clinias through the letters argument – you know all your letters? Yes. When anyone dictates, doesn't he dictate letters? Yes. Doesn't he dictate something you know? Yes. Therefore you are learning what you know. So you did not answer correctly. Then Dionysodorus threw the argument back like a ball: learning is the acquisition of knowledge, while knowing is already having knowledge, so those who acquire are those who do not have – the unlearned learn, not those who know. Well, Euthydemus was rushing in to give the lad a fall for the third time when I realised the young man was going under. Wanting to give him some respite I said, by way of encouragement, “Clinias, do not be surprised if these arguments appear unfamiliar to you. They are doing the same thing as those who are involved in Corybantic initiation – they are now really just dancing around you and having fun with these dance moves. After this they will initiate you.”

277e

I explained to Clinias that this was the playfulness of their instructions: they were demonstrating that the same word ‘learning’ applies both to someone who initially has no knowledge but subsequently acquires some, and to someone who already has the knowledge and investigates further. These men were demonstrating that this fact had escaped his notice, that the same word is applied to people in opposite circumstances. “So, you should regard all of this as child’s play on their part, after which they will of course demonstrate their serious work to you. So let that be the end of your game playing, Dionysodorus and Euthydemus, and that is probably enough. And so, after this you should give a demonstration in which you exhort the youth to devote himself to wisdom and excellence. But first I shall demonstrate to you both how I understand this, and the sort of thing I am eager to hear.”

278e

So I said, “Does every one of us wish to do well? Or is this question one of those that will provoke the laughter I was afraid of a moment ago? Yes, it is surely ridiculous even to ask such questions, for what man is there who does not wish to do well?” And Clinias agreed. “So be it. The next question is, since we wish to do well, how may we do well? Would it be by possessing much that is good? Come then, all things considered, what sort of things are good for us? Being wealthy, and being healthy too, and being handsome and endowed with the other bodily features?” He thought so too. “Then again, noble birth, power and esteem in your own city are obviously good.” He agreed. “And what about being sound-minded and just and courageous – are these good?” “They are good,” said Clinias. “And where shall we situate wisdom? With the good?” “With the good.”

279c

I then said we were in danger of omitting good fortune, which everyone agrees is the most important good of all – but then I changed my mind: “Surely wisdom is good fortune. Yes, a child would realise this.” I asked whether the flute players are the most fortunate when it comes to flute music, the writing teachers when it comes to letters, the wise pilot on the sea, the wise general in battle, the wise doctor when ill? In every case, Clinias agreed, wisdom brings good fortune, for wisdom would not ever fall into error. Rather, it must act aright and succeed, or else no longer be wisdom. In the end we both agreed, I know not how, that once wisdom is present, he to whom it is present needs no additional good fortune.

280b

I then took up the argument about using good things correctly. If we had a lot of food but did not eat, we would not be benefited. If each of the craftsmen had all the equipment appropriate to his own work but did not make use of it, they would not do well because of the acquisition alone. “So it seems that someone who is going to be happy must not merely acquire

such goods as these, but must also make use of them, or else no benefit arises from their acquisition.” Clinias agreed. “If he uses them correctly or if he does not?” “If he uses them correctly.” And was it knowledge that guided the right usage of everything – wealth, health, beauty? “It was knowledge,” said he. “So, in the case of any acquisition or any activity, knowledge not only provides people with good fortune, but also it ensures they do well.”

281a

I pressed on: would a person derive more benefit if he acquired a lot and did a lot without possessing intelligence, or if he acquired little and did little, while possessing intelligence? If he did less, wouldn't he make fewer errors, and wouldn't he be less wretched? “Entirely so.” Who is inclined to do less – someone rich or poor? “Someone poor.” Someone strong or weak? “Someone weak.” Someone courageous and sound-minded or a coward? “A coward.” And a lazy person, someone slow, dull of sight and hearing? We agreed with one another on all such examples. “To sum up, Clinias, in the case of everything we initially declared to be good, the argument is not about how they are naturally good just by themselves. If ignorance rules, then they are more bad than their opposites; but if understanding and wisdom rule, they are more good, yet just by themselves neither of them is of any value.”

281e

I concluded: “Since we are all eager to be happy, and since it turns out that we become like this through using things, and using them correctly, and since knowledge provides the correctness and good fortune, then every man should, it seems, contrive by every possible means to become as wise as possible. And surely if someone believes he should acquire this from his father, from his guardians too, and from his other friends, begging and imploring them to grant him wisdom is no disgrace, Clinias. Nor is there cause for indignation in being a

servant or slave to a lover or any person for the sake of this, in being willing to render any noble services out of his eagerness to become wise.” “I really think you have spoken rather well,” said he.

282c

I was delighted that Clinias agreed wisdom can be taught and I said, “Best of men, it is good that you say so, and you have done well, by saving me from a lengthy consideration of this very question, whether wisdom can or cannot be taught. So now, since you think both that it can be taught, and that it is the only thing there is that makes a person happy and fortunate, would you say anything else is needed, apart from the practice of philosophy? And is this what you yourself intend to do?” “Yes certainly, Socrates,” he replied, “to the best of my ability.” I was pleased to hear this, and I said, “Dionysodorus and Euthydemus, this is my own example – perhaps amateurish, laborious and a bit too long – of what I want an exhortatory argument to be like. Now, one of you, whoever wishes, should give a demonstration of the same thing, done skilfully. For it is of great importance to us that this youth become wise and good.”

283a

Now, Crito, that is what I said, and I paid very close attention to what was to happen next. Dionysodorus, the elder of the two, was first to set about the argument. “Tell me, Socrates,” said he, “and you others who say you want this youth to become wise. Are you joking when you say this, or are you serious, and do you truly want this?” So, with this in mind, I emphasised that we were extremely serious. And Dionysodorus said, “Well, think about this, Socrates, in case you end up denying what you are now saying.” “I have thought about it,” said I, “and I shall never end up denying it.” “Well then,” said he, “are you saying that you want him to become wise?” “Yes, we certainly are.” “And at the moment, is Clinias wise or not?” “He is not boastful,” said I, “and he does not yet make this claim.” “But,” said he, “you want

him to become what he is not, and no longer be what he now is.”

283b

When I heard this I was confused, and he seized upon my confused state and said, “Since you want him no longer to be what he now is, it seems you just want him to be dead. Yes, friends and lovers like these would be worth a lot, friends who would do anything to destroy their favourite.” When Ctesippus heard this, he was angry on behalf of his favourite and said, “Stranger from Thuri, if it were not such a crude expression, I would say ‘be it on your head’ for presuming to hold such a false notion of myself and the others, and one which in my view it is most unholy to express, that I would like this fellow to be utterly destroyed.” “What’s this, Ctesippus?” said Euthydemus. “Do you think it is possible to speak falsely?” “Yes, by Zeus,” he replied. “I would be mad not to.”

283c

Euthydemus then trapped Ctesippus: when one is speaking of a matter, does he not speak of something that is? And what he speaks of is one of the things that are? So if Dionysodorus is speaking of things that are, he is speaking the truth and is saying nothing false about you. Ctesippus retorted that Dionysodorus was speaking of things that are, but not as they actually are. “What do you mean?” said Dionysodorus. “Are there some people who speak of things as they are?” “There are, indeed,” he replied, “the noble and good, and those who speak the truth.” “What about this? What’s good is well disposed, and what’s bad badly so. Is this the case?” He concurred. “And you agree that the noble and good people speak of things as they are.” “I agree.” “So good people speak badly of anything bad, Ctesippus,” he said, “if they actually speak of it as it is?” This led to banter about speaking ‘greatly’ of the great and ‘warmly’ of the warm, and Dionysodorus accusing Ctesippus of being ‘abusive’.

284c

Since I thought they were being aggressive towards one another, I made light of it with Ctesippus, and said, “Ctesippus, if they are prepared to be generous, I think we should accept anything the strangers say, and not quarrel over a word. For if they know how to destroy people in such a way as to make worthy and intelligent folk out of those who are degenerate and stupid – if they know this, then let us make this concession to them. Let them destroy the lad for us and make him intelligent, and all the rest of us too. But if you younger folk are afraid, then let the danger fall upon me, as if they were practising on some slave. Since I am quite old, I am willing to run the risk and give myself over to Dionysodorus here as if he were Medea of Colchis. Let him destroy me, and if he wants to, let him boil me or do whatever he wants. Just let him bring me forth a worthy man.”

285d

Then the argument shifted to whether contradiction is possible. Dionysodorus said one could not even prove that one person had ever contradicted another. Ctesippus said he was hearing himself, Ctesippus, contradicting Dionysodorus right now. Dionysodorus pressed: are there accounts of each of the things that are? And do they not give an account of each as it is? But if both speakers give an account of the same thing, they say the same things – they don’t contradict. If neither speaks of the thing, neither mentions it. And if I speak of the thing but you speak of something else, then I’m speaking of it while you are not – but how could someone who does not speak of it contradict someone who does? Ctesippus fell silent, while I was amazed at the argument and said it always seemed to me to simply say there is no false speaking, and to ask whether there is false thinking. “There is no false thinking either,” he replied. “So there is no ignorance either, nor any ignorant people?”

286e

I asked directly: “Dionysodorus, are you presenting this argument for the sake of discussion, in order to say something unusual, or do you think in truth that there is no such thing as an ignorant person?” “You should try to refute me,” said he. “And based upon your argument, is there refutation when no one speaks falsely?” “There is not,” said Euthydemus. “Then Dionysodorus did not encourage me to refute him just now?” said I. “Indeed, how could someone encourage what is not?” I pressed on: if it is impossible to be in error either when acting, speaking or thinking, what have the two of you come here to teach? Or did you not claim earlier that you are the best people to impart excellence to someone who wishes to learn it? Dionysodorus dismissed this as old Cronus-talk, reminding me of what was said last year and refusing to deal with what was being said at the moment.

287e

After much back-and-forth, in which Euthydemus tried to trap me into saying I know by my soul and I always know, I resolved to get back to the exhortatory purpose and said, “Clinias, you should remind me where we left off. As I recall it was around the stage where we agreed, in the end, that one should practise philosophy.” “Yes,” he replied. “And philosophy is the acquisition of knowledge. Isn’t this the case?” “Yes.” “Now, would it be of any benefit to us if, as we went about, we knew how to recognise where most gold is buried beneath the earth?” “Probably,” he replied. “But we refuted this suggestion earlier,” said I, “because we would be no better off even if all the earth’s gold were to be ours without any trouble, or any need to dig. And so even if we knew how to turn stones into gold, the knowledge would be of no value, for if we did not also know how to use the gold, there turned out to be no benefit in it. Don’t you remember?” “Entirely so,” he replied.

289a

So what is needed is a knowledge in which the production, and knowing how to use what is produced, reside together. We do not need to be lyre makers, for the productive skill is one thing while the user's skill is another. The same holds for flute-making. I asked about the speech-writer's skill, and Clinias objected: "I notice that some speechwriters do not know how to deliver their own speeches, the ones they have composed, just as the lyre makers are unable to play the lyres – the skill of producing speeches is distinct from the skill of using them." I thought that you are giving sufficient evidence that the skill of the speech-makers is not the one whose acquisition would result in happiness. Indeed, this skill is a portion of the enchanters' skill, but a little inferior thereto. For the skill of the enchanters consists in charming snakes and wild creatures generally, while the speech-makers' skill involves charming and persuading jurors, assembly members, and large gatherings in general.

290a

I suggested the skill of the general next, but Clinias said, "This is, in a sense, a skill in hunting down human beings. Nothing in the actual skill of hunting goes any further than hunting down and subduing, and whenever hunters subdue whatever they are hunting, they are not able to make use of it. Instead the hunters hand it over to the cooks. The same goes for geometers, astronomers and calculators, since they too are hunters. They do not produce their own diagrams; instead, they make discoveries. And since they themselves do not know how to make use of them, but only how to hunt them down, they hand over, of course, to the dialecticians. And the same goes for the generals: whenever they capture some city or army, they hand it over to the statesmen. So if we need a particular skill which also knows how to make use of that which it acquires, then we must search for something else rather than the skill of the general."

290c

Crito: What are you saying, Socrates? Did that young man make a pronouncement of that sort?

Socrates: Don't you believe it, Crito?

Crito: By Zeus, I don't. In fact, if he said all that, I think he needs neither Euthydemus nor anyone else to educate him.

290d

Socrates: Well then, by heaven, perhaps it was Ctesippus who said all this and I am being forgetful? In any case, I know quite well that it was neither Euthydemus nor Dionysodorus who said all this. But, blessed Crito, was it perhaps one of the superior beings in the vicinity who made the pronouncement? For I know that I did hear all this.

290e

Crito: Yes by Zeus, Socrates, I think it was indeed one of the superior beings, very much so. But after that, did you continue searching for some sort of skill? Did you or did you not find the skill you were searching for?

Socrates: Did we find it? Heavens, no. But we were quite comical fellows, just like children chasing after larks, constantly believing we were just on the point of capturing each of the kinds of knowledge, while they kept on escaping us. Once we had arrived at the art of kingship, and we were considering it closely in case it might be the one that provides happiness, we ended up in a sort of labyrinth. Thinking we were already at the end, having turned another corner, we appeared to be back at the beginning of the search once more, and just as badly off as we were at the outset.

291a

Crito: How did that happen to you, Socrates?

Socrates: I'll tell you. The fact is, we had presumed that the skill of statesmanship and the skill of kingship were the same. The

skill of generalship and the others hand over to this skill to take charge of their works, since it alone knows how to make use of them. So it seemed evident to us that this was what we were seeking, and was the cause of right action in the city, simply, as the line from Aeschylus says, seated alone at the helm of the city, governing all, in charge of all, making everything useful.

291d

Crito: Well, was your understanding unsound, Socrates?

291e

Socrates: You will decide, Crito, if you are willing to hear what happened to us after this. When we asked what outcome the skill of kingship brings about for us – as medical skill brings health, and the skill of agriculture brings food from the earth – we found we couldn't say what it produces. Eventually, Clinias and I agreed that good is presumably nothing but knowledge of some sort. So the skill of kingship had to make the citizens wise and confer knowledge, if it was really going to be the one that benefits them and makes them happy.

292c

Crito: That's it. So, based upon your report of the discussion, this was presumably agreed by yourselves at that stage.

Socrates: Well then, does the skill of kingship make the people wise and good?

Crito: Is there any reason why not, Socrates?

292d

Socrates: But does it make everyone good at everything? And is this the skill that confers all knowledge – shoe-making, carpentry, and all the others?

Crito: No, Socrates, I don't think so.

Socrates: Well, what knowledge does it confer? Now, it should not be the artificer of any of the outcomes that are neither good nor bad, yet it should confer no knowledge apart from itself. Is

it acceptable if we say that it is that by which we shall make others good?

Crito: Entirely so.

292e

Socrates: In what respect will they be good and useful for us? Or would we continue to say that they will make others so, and those others will do this too? But it is not at all evident to us in what exact respect they are good, especially since we have discredited the outcomes ascribed to statesmanship. No, it is simply a case of the proverb, ‘Corinthos, son of Zeus’, and as I said, we were just as badly off, or even worse off, when it came to knowing what the knowledge that will make us happy actually is.

293a

Crito: By Zeus, Socrates, it seems you ended up in considerable difficulty.

Socrates: Now, I myself, Crito, since I had landed in this difficulty, began to exclaim at the top of my voice, begging the two strangers to rescue us, myself and the young man, from the third wave of the argument, to be serious in every way, and reveal to us, in all seriousness, what precisely is the knowledge which we should obtain if we are to live out the rest of our lives beautifully.

293b

Crito: Well then, was Euthydemus prepared to reveal anything to you?

Socrates: Of course, and he began his account, my friend, in a very high-minded manner, as follows. “Well, Socrates, this knowledge that has perplexed you for so long, shall I teach it to you, or show you that you possess it?” “Blessed man,” said I, “is it within your power to do this?” “It certainly is,” he replied. “Then show me that I possess it, by Zeus, since for a man of my

age that will be much easier than learning it.” He asked if there is anything I know. “Certainly,” I replied. “That’s enough,” said he. “Now, do you think it is possible for anything at all not to be just what it happens to be?” “By Zeus, I do not.” “And you do know something?” “I do.” “In that case you are knowledgeable, if you actually know.” “Certainly, in relation to that ‘something’.” “That makes no difference. Isn’t it necessary that you know everything since you are knowledgeable?” “Heavens,” said I, “even when there is so much else that I do not know?” “Well then, if there is something you do not know, you are not knowledgeable.”

294a

By Zeus,” said I, “what a wonder you are describing. Great good has come to light. But surely all the rest of the people don’t know either everything or nothing?” “Well, presumably,” said he, “it is not the case that they know some things while not knowing others. Everyone knows everything, if they actually know even one thing.” And under questioning by Ctesippus they did accept that they knew everything, case by case. There was nothing that Ctesippus did not ask them, no matter how base it was. Yet the two men met his questions most valiantly, just like boars that are driven towards an onslaught. As a result, I myself was compelled in the end to ask, incredulously, if Dionysodorus knew how to dance, and he replied, “Certainly.” “I do not suppose that at your age, you have attained such advanced wisdom that you can also somersault over swords, and be spun about on a wheel, have you?” “There is nothing I cannot do,” he replied. “And when you were children, even at the moment you were born, did you know everything?” They both said yes, simultaneously.

295b

Euthydemus wanted to prove I accept these amazing propositions too. He asked if I know what I know by means of something. “By the soul.” He pressed: do you always know by

this same means? Always? Do you know some things by means of this and others by means of something else, or do you know all things by this? “I know all things by this,” I replied, “whatever I know at any rate.” Through careful stripping of qualifications like ‘whatever I know’ and ‘whenever I know’, he got me to say simply “Always” and “All things.” Then he announced: “Now, you have also accepted that you always know by means of that whereby you know. So it is obvious that you knew as a child, even when you were being born, even when you were being conceived. Even before you yourself were born, even before heaven and earth came into being, you knew all things, since you always know. And indeed, by Zeus, you yourself always will know, and will know all things, if it so pleases me.”

296e

I asked him to tell me how I may say that I know such things as that good men are unjust. “You know, indeed,” he replied. “What?” said I. “That good men are not unjust.” “Yes, I’ve always known that,” said I. “But I am asking where I learned that the good people are unjust.” “Nowhere,” replied Dionysodorus. “Then I do not know this,” said I. “You are ruining the argument,” said Euthydemus to Dionysodorus, “and this fellow will turn out not to have known this, and to be knowledgeable and not knowledgeable at the same time.” Dionysodorus blushed. And I said, “I am certainly inferior to Heracles, who was not able to do battle with the hydra, a sophistical creature so clever that if someone cut off one head of the argument, she sent forth many more in its place. He could not do battle with her and with some other sophistical crab recently emerged from the sea, who so pained Heracles by talking and biting from his left-hand side that he called for the help of his nephew, Iolaus. But if my Iolaus were to arrive, he would just make matters worse.”

297d

Then Dionysodorus pursued a new line: “Was Iolaus any more the nephew of Heracles than yours?” Through careful steps he had me admit that Patrocles is my brother, then established that their father Chaeredemus was a father while being other than mine, and since being other than a father means not being a father, that Sophroniscus likewise, being other than Chaeredemus, is not a father. “And so you, Socrates, are fatherless,” said Euthydemus. Then Ctesippus took up the argument: is Euthydemus’ father, being other than my father, the same? “The same, indeed.” “But, Euthydemus, is he my father only, or is he the father of everyone else too?” “Of everyone else too. Or do you think the same man, being a father, is not a father?” This extended to their mother being the mother of sea urchins, and themselves being brothers to gudgeons, puppies and piglets.

298e

Then Dionysodorus asked whether Ctesippus has a dog. “Yes, a very nasty one.” Does he have puppies? “Yes, and they are very like himself.” “So the dog is their father?” “Yes, I saw him covering the bitch myself.” “Well now, isn’t the dog yours? In that case, he is a father and he is yours, and so he turns out to be your father, and you turn out to be the brother of puppies.” Then Dionysodorus quickly interrupted: “Answer this little question for me. Do you beat this dog?” Ctesippus laughed and said, “Yes, by the gods, since I can’t do it to you.” “Aren’t you beating your own father then?”

299b

Euthydemus asked whether it is a benefit for a sick person to drink medicine when he needs to, and whether in battle it is better to go wearing armour. Ctesippus agreed. “Indeed, since you accept that it is a benefit for a man to drink medicine when necessary, shouldn’t he simply drink this beneficial substance as much as possible? And in that case, would it be an advantage if someone were to grind and blend a wagon-load of hellebore for

him?” Ctesippus replied, “Very much so, Euthydemus, particularly if the man who drinks it is the size of the big statue at Delphi.” And in battle, since it is a benefit to wear armour, should we carry as many spears and shields as possible? Ctesippus quipped whether they would arm Geryon¹² and Briareus in this way.

299d

Then Dionysodorus asked whether it is a benefit to possess gold and to have benefits at all times and in all places. And should gold be especially in ourselves? “Would a person be supremely blessed if he were to have three talents of gold in his stomach, a talent in his skull, and a stater of gold in each eye?” Ctesippus retorted that the most blessed of the Scythians¹³, and their very best men, are the ones who have a lot of gold in their own skulls, and that they drink from their own gilded skulls. Then Euthydemus produced another ambiguity: the Scythians and others see what is ‘capable of vision¹⁴’ – which is ambiguous between ‘capable of seeing’ and ‘capable of being seen’ – and so our cloaks, being capable of being seen, are ‘capable of vision’. And do our cloaks see nothing? “To me, Euthydemus,” said Ctesippus, “you seem to have fallen asleep, without being asleep, and if it is possible to speak yet say nothing, that is just what you are doing.”

300d

The discussion moved to whether a speaking of what is silent¹⁵ is possible, and a silence of speaking. Euthydemus asked: when you are silent, are you silent in relation to all things? “I am.” Aren’t you also silent in relation to whatever speaks, if this is included in all things? And since the different is not silent, do all things speak? Dionysodorus jumped in with “Neither and both – yes, I know quite well that you will not be able to deal with this answer.” And Ctesippus, in his usual way, broke into very loud laughter and said, “Euthydemus, your brother has led the argument into a contradiction, and he has perished and been

defeated.” Now, Clinias was extremely pleased, and he laughed, with the result that Ctesippus grew in stature tenfold.

300e

And I said, “Clinias, why are you laughing at matters that are so serious and beautiful?” “Well, Socrates,” said Dionysodorus, “have you ever yet seen a beautiful matter?” “Yes, I have, Dionysodorus, lots of them.” “So are they different from the beautiful, or the same as the beautiful?” And I became utterly perplexed, but I said they were different from the beautiful, although some beauty is present with each of them. “So, if an ox is present with you, you are an ox, and because I am present with you now, you are Dionysodorus?” “What a thing to say,” said I. “But what way could the different be different, just because difference is present with difference?” I asked if the beautiful is not beautiful and the base not base? “If it seems so to me.” “And indeed the two of you seem to me to bring the process of dialectic to fruition, just like craftsmen who bring their appropriate work to fruition.”

301c

Then Dionysodorus led me into another trap: to whom is brass-working appropriate? To the brass-workers. Making pots? To the potters. Cutting up, skinning¹⁶, boiling or roasting the portions of meat once cut up? To the cook. And if someone enacts what is appropriate, isn't he acting aright? So if someone slaughters the cook, cuts him up and boils and roasts him, he will be acting aright? “By Poseidon,” said I, “at this stage you are putting the finishing touches to your wisdom. I wonder, will it ever be mine, and become my own?” Then through steps about what things are mine (those I can sell, give away or sacrifice), and about living creatures (those that have soul), and about my ancestral gods Apollo¹⁷, Zeus and Athena being mine and living creatures, he asked: since you have agreed that Zeus and the other gods are yours, are you allowed to sell them, or give them away, or treat them as you wish, just like any other

living creatures?

303a

Well, Crito, while I lay there speechless, as though I had been felled by the argument, Ctesippus came to my aid saying, “Bravo Heracles, what a good argument.” And Dionysodorus asked, “Is Heracles a bravo, or a bravo Heracles?” And Ctesippus responded, “By Poseidon, what formidable arguments. I give up. The two men are invincible.”

303b

With that, dear Crito, I must say that there was no one present who did not heap praises upon the two men and their argument. Indeed, they almost died laughing, clapping and rejoicing. Now even the very columns of the Lyceum came close to applause and delight at these two men. As for myself, I was reduced to admitting that no one had ever before beheld any people who were as wise as they were, and being utterly captivated by the wisdom of the pair, I took to praising and eulogising them both, saying: “You are two blessed men, possessed of a wondrous nature, who have perfected such a subject so readily in such a short period of time. The most exalted of your arguments is that you have no concern for most of humanity, nor indeed for important people or those with a reputation, but only for those who are similar to yourselves. For I know quite well that there are very few people similar to yourselves who would be content with these arguments, while everyone else is so unappreciative of them that they would be more ashamed to refute others by such arguments than to be refuted themselves.”

303d

I continued: “There is also an appealing and kindly aspect to your arguments. Whenever you declare that there is nothing beautiful, nothing good or white, and so on, and that nothing is at all different from anything else, you simply stitch up people’s mouths well and truly. Yet, because you don’t just do this to

others but you seem also to do it to your own mouths, this is entirely delightful and it takes away the offensive aspect of the arguments. And yet, what is most significant is that you have arranged matters and contrived them so skilfully that anyone at all can learn this in a short period of time. I realised this myself by paying attention to Ctesippus, and how quickly he was able to imitate you without any preparation. Now, the fact that this business of yours is readily imparted is all very well, but it is not appropriate for discussion before a general audience. It is best, rather, that the two of you conduct your discussions only with one another. Failing that, it should be someone who is paying you a fee. And if you are sensible, you will also give the same advice to your pupils: never to conduct a discussion with anyone else. For whatever is scarce is valuable, Euthydemus, while water is cheapest, although it is the best, as Pindar says.”

304b

Socrates: Having discussed all this, Crito, and some other issues that took less time, we departed. Now, you should consider how you are going to join us as a pupil of these two men who claim to be able to teach anyone who is willing to pay them, and who say that neither a person’s nature nor his age prevents anyone at all from easily acquiring their wisdom. And it is most important for you to hear that, according to them, this wisdom is not an impediment to making money.

304c

Crito: Well, Socrates, although I myself love listening to discussions, and would be pleased to learn something, I fear that I too am one of those people who would prefer being refuted by such arguments as these, rather than refuting someone else. Now, although it seems ridiculous to be giving you a warning, I want to report what I heard nevertheless. The fact is that one of the people coming from your gathering approached me as I was out and about, a man who regards himself as extremely wise, a formidable figure when it comes to writing speeches for use in

law courts. “Crito,” said he, “are you taking no lessons from these wise men?” I replied that when I was standing near them I was unable to hear clearly because of the crowd. “And yet,” said he, “it was worth hearing, at any rate.” I asked what his overall impression was. “It was just the sort of thing you always hear from people like this, babbling and making a useless fuss about nothing of any consequence.”

304d

Crito: And I said, “But surely philosophy is something graceful?” “Graceful in what way, blessed man?” he asked. “It is of no value at all. And had you actually been there, I think you would have been utterly ashamed on behalf of your own friend, so strangely did he behave, willing to surrender himself to men who care not what they say, and fasten upon every word that is spoken. And these fellows are counted among the most influential people of this day and age. But the fact is, Crito, that the subject itself, and the people who devote their time to the subject, are worthless and ridiculous.” Now, Socrates, it did not seem right to me for him or anyone else to criticise the subject. However, it did seem right to apportion blame for your willingness to engage in discourse with such people as these, in front of a large audience.

305a

Socrates: Crito, men like these are marvels. However, I do not yet know what I am to say to you. What sort of person was he who approached you and apportioned blame to philosophy? Was he one of the formidable combatants from the law courts, a rhetorician? Or was he one of the people who sends them into battle, a composer of speeches with which the rhetoricians engage in combat?

Crito: By Zeus, he is not a rhetorician at all, nor do I think he has ever appeared in court. Yet they say he understands the business, and that he is formidable, and composes formidable

speeches.

Socrates: Now I understand. I was just about to speak about these people myself. For although they are, according to Prodicus, on the boundary between the philosopher and the statesman, they think that they are the wisest men of all. And they believe that the only thing preventing them from being well regarded by everyone are people who engage in philosophy. So they believe that if they reduce the reputation of these people, and make them seem worthless, the victory prize will indisputably be theirs immediately, a reputation for wisdom in the eyes of all. So they maintain that they are in truth the wisest, and whenever they get tangled up in arguments of a private nature, that they are being worsted by Euthydemus and his followers. Yet they believe quite plausibly that they are extremely wise for they possess a measure of philosophy and a measure of statesmanship. So, remaining aloof from danger and conflict, they reap the harvest of wisdom.

306a

Crito: What of it, Socrates? Do you think they have a point since their argument does have a certain neatness at least?

Socrates: Yes, indeed, Crito, it does indeed possess neatness rather than truth. For if philosophy is good, and so too is the activity of the statesman, each in a different respect, and these fellows are in between those two since they partake of both, then they do not have a point since they are inferior with respect to both. And if one is good and the other bad, then they are better with respect to one group and worse with respect to the other. But if both are bad, in that case and in no other, they would be speaking the truth to an extent. But the fact of the matter is that these fellows, although they partake of both, are inferior with respect to both, with respect to what is of value in statesmanship and what is of value in philosophy, and despite being, in truth, in third place, they are ambitious to be regarded

as first. So we should forgive this ambition of theirs and not be troubled, yet still recognise that they are the sort of people they are. For we ought to admire any man whatsoever who says anything that conforms to good sense and takes the trouble to pursue it courageously.

306d

Crito: Yes, indeed, Socrates, and I myself, as I am always telling you, am perplexed over my sons and how I should deal with them. Now, one of them is still young and little, but Critobulus is now at an age where he needs someone who will do something for him. Now, whenever I am in your company, you always have the same effect. I think that it is madness to have taken such trouble in so many different ways for the sake of my children – trouble in relation to marriage to ensure noble birth on their mother's side, and trouble over making money – whilst I neglected their education. Yet, whenever I look at any of those people who profess to educate humanity, I am shocked, and each one of them seems to me, on reflection, to be utterly outlandish, to tell you the truth between ourselves. And so I do not know how I am to turn the young man towards philosophy.

307a

Socrates: Crito, my friend, don't you realise that in every activity the inferior practitioners are numerous and of no value, while the serious ones are few, and valuable beyond measure? And don't you think that gymnastics is a worthy activity, money-making too, and rhetoric and generalship?

307b

Crito: Entirely so, of course I do.

Socrates: Well then, in each of those cases, don't you know that most people are comical exponents of the particular role?

Crito: Yes, by Zeus, that is certainly true.

Socrates: So, will you yourself shun all of these activities on account of this, and refuse to direct your son towards them?

307c

Crito: That wouldn't be right, Socrates.

Socrates: Then do not do what you should not do, Crito. Rather, bid farewell to the exponents of philosophy, whether they be worthy or base, and having tested the subject itself well and truly, turn not just your sons but every man away from it if it proves in your eyes to be unworthy. However, if it proves to be as I think it is, then pursue it and practise it with all your heart, both you and yours, as the saying goes.

NOTES

1. This is a reference to Clinias, who becomes involved later in the dialogue.
2. A reference to the King of the Persian (Achaemenid) Empire.
3. The Corybantes were armed, crested male dancers who worshipped the goddess Cybele. They also conducted a male coming-of-age ritual connected with the victory of a warrior in battle.
4. According to legend, Medea had the power to reanimate dismembered bodies and rejuvenate the elderly. Having seen her reconstitute a ram that had been cut up and put into a stew, and desirous that their father should be returned to his youth, the daughters of King Pelias cut him up and put him in a pot, but Medea never performed the ceremony.
5. Marsyas was a Satyr who, according to legend, challenged Apollo to a music contest and lost. As punishment, he chose to have his hide used as a wine-skin.
6. Cronus, the father of Zeus, who was overthrown by his son, represents things that are past their time.
7. Meneleus forced Proteus to reveal which of the gods he had offended so that he could make amends and find his way home. *Odyssey* iv.456 ff.
8. The quote is likely to be from *Seven Against Thebes*.
9. This proverb involves needless repetition because Corinthus was the son of Zeus.
10. Castor and Pollux, known as the *dioscuri*, were protectors of seafarers.
11. Hellebore is a plant now known to be toxic but which was used in ancient medicine to treat various conditions, including mental disorders.
12. Geryon and Briareus were two fearsome mythological creatures. The first was a giant with multiple heads and multiple bodies; the second was a giant with one hundred arms.
13. Herodotus, iv.65, describes the Scythians as gilding the skulls of their enemies and drinking from them.
14. The Greek phrase translated 'capable of vision' is ambiguous between 'capable of seeing' and 'capable of being seen'.
15. The Greek phrases translated 'a speaking of what is silent' and 'a silence of speaking' are ambiguous between 'a speaking by a thing that is silent' and 'a speaking about a thing that is silent'.

16. The Greek phrase translated here is ambiguous between ‘it is appropriate for the cook that the cook engages in cutting and skinning’ and ‘it is appropriate for the cook that one engages in the cutting and skinning of the cook’.

17. According to legend, Ion was the son of Apollo and Creusa. Euripides, *Ion* 61-75.

18. *Olympian* i.1.

Euthyphro

ΕΥΘΥΦΡΩΝ

Plato

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persons in the dialogue:

EUTHYPHRO a diviner-priest, nothing else is known about him

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

scene: outside the Royal Stoa in the Athenian Agora

2a

Euthyphro: What ever is going on, Socrates? You have left your usual haunt in the Lyceum¹ and you are now spending time here at the Royal Stoa.² Surely you too do not have a suit before the Royal Archon, as I do.

Socrates: Well, Athenians, Euthyphro, do not call it a suit, but a prosecution.

2b

Euthyphro: What are you saying? Then someone is prosecuting you it seems, for I shall not accuse you of prosecuting someone else.

Socrates: Of course not.

Euthyphro: Is someone prosecuting you then?

Socrates: Yes, indeed.

Euthyphro: Who is he?

Socrates: I hardly even know the man myself, Euthyphro. Apparently he is someone young and unknown. Anyway, his name, I believe, is Meletus. He belongs to the deme³ of Pittheus, if you can think of a Meletus from Pittheus with straight hair, not much of a beard, and a hook nose.

Euthyphro: I cannot think of anyone, Socrates. But tell me, what charge has he brought against you?

2c

Socrates: What charge? Well, it is no ordinary charge, in my opinion anyway. Indeed, it is quite an achievement for a young man to have understood a matter of such importance. For this

fellow claims to know how the young people are being corrupted and who their corrupters are. And he is probably wise, and having discerned my ignorance he goes to the city, just as a child runs to its mother, accusing me of corrupting people of his own age. And it looks to me as if he alone embarks upon his political career in the right way, for it is right to care for the young people first so that they turn out as good as they possibly can, just as a good farmer is likely to care first for the young plants, and after that for the others. And in fact, Meletus is probably clearing us out first, the destroyers of the crop of youth, as he says. Then, of course, once he has cared for the older generation as well, he will be responsible for great benefits aplenty to our city. At least, that would be the likely outcome of setting about it in this way.

3a

Euthyphro: Would that it were so, Socrates, but I fear that the outcome may turn out to be the very opposite. In fact, I think he is actually starting off by damaging the very heart of our city by attacking you unjustly. But tell me, how exactly does he say you corrupt the young?

3b

Socrates: It sounds absurd, my wonderful friend, on first hearing at any rate. For he says that I am an inventor of gods, and on the grounds that I am inventing new gods and disregarding the old ones, he is prosecuting me on their behalf, so he says.

Euthyphro: I understand, Socrates. It's because you say that the divine sign comes to you from time to time. So he has prosecuted you on this charge, as an innovator in matters divine, and he goes into court to slander you, knowing that such issues are easily misrepresented to most people. Indeed, in my own case too, whenever I say anything in the Assembly about matters divine, predicting the future for them, they laugh at me

as if I were a madman, and yet nothing I foretold has not come true. But nevertheless, they are jealous of everyone like us. However, we must not worry about them, but face up to them.

3c

Socrates: Dear Euthyphro, being laughed at is perhaps not an issue. Indeed, the Athenians, in my view, are not greatly concerned if they believe that someone is clever, provided of course he does not set about teaching his own wisdom. But if they believe he is also making other people turn out like himself, they get angry, either out of jealousy, as you say, or for some other reason.

Euthyphro: Well, I am not very keen to test their precise attitude to me on this issue.

Socrates: Well, perhaps you have a reputation for holding yourself aloof and being reluctant to teach your own wisdom, while I am afraid lest, due to my love of humanity, I have a reputation in their eyes for saying whatever I have to say without restraint to anyone I meet, free of charge, and not only that, but I would gladly pay someone who was prepared to listen to me. Well, as I was saying just now, if they are going to laugh at me just as you say they laugh at you, it might be quite pleasant to spend our time having fun and laughing in the courtroom. But if, on the other hand, they are going to be serious, then it is unclear how the issue will turn out, except to soothsayers like yourself.

3d

Euthyphro: Well, Socrates, perhaps it will all come to nothing. You will contest your suit in the way you see fit, and I think I shall do the same with mine.

3e

Socrates: But, Euthyphro, what is this suit of yours? Are you defending or prosecuting?

Euthyphro: I am prosecuting.

Socrates: Whom?

Euthyphro: Someone whom I am regarded as mad, once more, for prosecuting.

Socrates: Why so? Are you prosecuting someone who can fly?

Euthyphro: He is very far indeed from flying. In fact, he happens to be well on in years.

Socrates: Who is the man?

Euthyphro: My father.

4a

Socrates: Your father, my good man?

Euthyphro: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: But what is the charge? And what is your suit about?

Euthyphro: Murder, Socrates.

Socrates: By Heracles, Euthyphro! Most people are presumably unaware of the proper procedure here. For I do not believe it is appropriate for any random person to do this, but only someone who is presumably already far advanced in wisdom.

Euthyphro: Far advanced indeed, by Zeus, Socrates.

Socrates: And was it some member of your family who was killed by your father? Of course it was, for I presume you would not have prosecuted your father for murder on account of a stranger.

4b

Euthyphro: It's amusing, Socrates, that you think it makes any difference whether the murdered man was a stranger or a family member, instead of attending to the single issue of whether the killer killed his victim justly or unjustly. And if he acted justly, one should leave him be. However, if he acted

unjustly, one should prosecute him, especially if the killer shares your hearth and your table. For equal is the pollution that befalls you if you live with such a person, knowing what he knows, without purifying yourself and that person by bringing him to justice. In this case, the man who was slain was a day-labourer of mine, and when we were farming on Naxos he worked on our land. One day, mad with wine, he got angry with one of our slaves and slit his throat. So my father bound him hand and foot, threw him into a ditch, and sent a man here to Athens to find out from the legal expositor what he should do. Meanwhile, he showed no regard for the man he had tied up and neglected him, since he was a murderer, and it did not matter even if he should die, which is exactly what happened to him. Before the messenger arrived back from the legal expositor, the man died from hunger, the cold, and his bonds.

Well, my father and the rest of my family are obviously angry over this, because I am prosecuting my father for murder on behalf of the murderer. They maintain that he did not actually kill the man, and even if he did definitely kill him the slain man was a murderer anyway, and I should not be concerned over someone like this, because it is unholy for a son to prosecute his father for murder. So poor is their knowledge of the divine realm, Socrates, and where it stands in relation to what is holy and what is unholy!

4e

Socrates: But, by Zeus, Euthyphro, do you believe that you understand divine matters in relation to holiness and unholiness so precisely that you are not afraid, given the circumstances you are describing, of performing a further unholy action yourself by bringing your father to justice?

5a

Euthyphro: Socrates, I would be useless indeed, and Euthyphro would not be different from anybody else, if I did not have precise knowledge of all such matters.

Socrates: In that case, wonderful Euthyphro, my best course of action is to become your pupil and challenge Meletus on these very issues in advance of his prosecution. I will do so by saying that, heretofore, I have always attached great importance to knowledge of divine matters, and now, since the man claims that I am falling into error through my rash utterances and innovations on matters divine, I have become your pupil. I would then say, “Dear Meletus, if you accept that Euthyphro is wise in such matters, then you should also believe that my views too are sound and drop the charge. Otherwise, rather than prosecuting me, prosecute Euthyphro, my teacher, for corrupting his elders, myself and his own father, by instructing me and censuring and punishing him.” And if I did not convince him, and he did not drop the charge, or prosecute you instead of me, I would say the very same things in court as in my pre-trial challenge.

5c

Euthyphro: Yes, by Zeus, Socrates! And if he were to attempt to prosecute me, I think I would find where his weak point lies, and our argument in court would be concerned with him long before it concerned me.

Socrates: Yes, my dear friend, and I am eager to become your pupil because I recognise all this. I know that neither this man Meletus, nor anyone else I presume, seems even to notice you, yet he picked me out immediately, with so little difficulty that he has prosecuted me for impiety. Now then, tell me, by Zeus, what you claimed a moment ago to know full well. What sort of thing, according to you, is pious, and what is impious, in relation to murder or in relation to anything else? Is not the holy itself the same as itself, while the unholy is, in turn, the

opposite of everything holy, yet like itself? In other words, anything that is to be unholy possesses a single form based upon unholiness?

5d

Euthyphro: Of course, Socrates, entirely so.

Socrates: Tell me then, according to you, what is holiness and what is unholiness?

Euthyphro: Well, I say that what is holy is exactly what I am doing now, prosecuting the wrongdoer for murder, for robbing temples, or for committing any other crimes of that sort, even if he happens to be your father or mother or anyone else, while failure to prosecute is unholy. Now, Socrates, behold what convincing evidence I shall present of the law that this is the case, evidence I have already given to others, showing that these events are unfolding as they should, and we should not give way to an impious person no matter who that person happens to be. For people regard Zeus as the best and most just of the gods, and they accept that he bound his own father, Cronus, for unjustly devouring his children, and that he, Cronus, in turn, had castrated his own father for similar reasons. Yet they are angry with me for prosecuting my father for acting unjustly, and so when speaking about the gods and when speaking about me, they are contradicting themselves.

6a

Socrates: Well, Euthyphro, could this be the reason I am being prosecuted, because whenever someone tells me stories of this kind about the gods, I accept them only with some reluctance? Because of this, it seems, someone may well declare that I am in error. So now, if you who understand such matters so well also approve of these stories, then it seems that I need to go along with them too. For what else can someone say when they admit that they know nothing about these matters? But tell me, in the name of friendship, do you believe in truth that these things

happened in this way?

6b

Euthyphro: Yes Socrates, and there are stories, even stranger than these, that most people do not know about.

Socrates: So, do you also believe that there really is war between the gods, bitter enmities, battles, and lots of other things like these, as recounted by the poets? These also adorn our sacred places, courtesy of the fine painters, and, in particular, the robe that is carried up to the Acropolis at the Great Panathenaea is full of depictions of this kind. Are we to say that these are all true, Euthyphro?

Euthyphro: Not only that, Socrates, but, as I said just now, I shall, if you like, relate lots of other stories to you about matters divine, which, on hearing, I know full well you will be astonished.

6c

Socrates: I would not be surprised. But you can recount these to me at your leisure on some other occasion. Right now, please try to answer the question I asked you a moment ago, more clearly. For you did not instruct me adequately, my friend, when I asked you earlier what precisely holiness is. Instead, you told me that this action you are performing, prosecuting your father for murder, is holy.

Euthyphro: And I told you the truth, Socrates.

Socrates: Perhaps, Euthyphro, but in fact you say that lots of other things are holy too.

Euthyphro: And so they are.

6d

Socrates: May I remind you, Euthyphro, that this is not what I asked you to teach me about – one or two of the many holy actions – but about that very form by which everything that is holy, is holy. For I think you said that what is unholy is unholy,

and what is holy is holy, by a single form, or do you not remember?

Euthyphro: I remember.

Socrates: Well, what precisely is this form? Teach me, so that I may focus upon it, and using this as a standard, declare that any action that is like this standard is holy, and any action that is unlike it is not, whether it is performed by you or by anyone else.

6e

Euthyphro: Well, Socrates, if you want me to express it in those terms, I shall do so.

Socrates: Yes, that is what I want.

Euthyphro: Well then, what is loved by the gods is holy, but what is not loved by them is unholy.

7a

Socrates: Excellent, Euthyphro! You have now answered in the way that I asked you to answer, although I do not yet know if you have answered truthfully. But of course, you will go on to explain that what you are saying is true.

Euthyphro: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Come on then, let us consider what we are saying: whatever is beloved of the gods, and the person who is beloved of the gods, is holy, and whatever is hated by the gods, and whoever is hated by them, is unholy. And the holy is not the same as the unholy, but is its complete opposite. Is this not so?

Euthyphro: It is so, indeed.

Socrates: And what we are saying is, apparently, correct?

7b

Euthyphro: I think so, Socrates.

Socrates: But Euthyphro, was it not also stated that the gods quarrel and differ with one another, and that there is enmity between them?

Euthyphro: Yes, that was stated.

Socrates: But what is the disagreement about when it generates enmity and anger? Let us consider this. Suppose you and I differ about which of two numbers is greater. Would our disagreement about these generate enmity and make us angry with one another, or would we quickly settle these matters by engaging in calculation, in such cases as these at any rate?

7c

Euthyphro: Of course.

Socrates: And if we were to differ about the greater and the lesser, we would quickly put an end to our dispute through engaging in measurement?

Euthyphro: Yes.

Socrates: And I think we would decide about what is heavier and what is lighter by engaging in weighing?

Euthyphro: Of course.

Socrates: When we become enemies and get angry with one another, what then might our disagreement be about? What issue might we be unable to resolve? Perhaps you cannot answer readily, but I will make a suggestion. Consider if the issue at hand is the just and the unjust, beautiful and ugly, good and bad. Aren't these issues we disagree about, and being unable to come to an adequate resolution do we not become enemies whenever this happens to you and me, or to anyone else?

7d

Euthyphro: Yes, Socrates, this is the disagreement in question, and it concerns these issues.

Socrates: But what about the gods, Euthyphro? If they do, in fact, disagree on anything, would they not disagree on these very issues?

Euthyphro: This must be so.

7e

Socrates: And in fact, according to your account, noble Euthyphro, there are differing views among the gods themselves as to what is just and unjust, beautiful, ugly, good or bad, for they would not have quarrelled with one another if they had not differed on these issues. Is this so?

Euthyphro: What you are saying is correct.

Socrates: Would not the quarrelling parties love anything they themselves regard as beautiful, good, or just, and would they not hate the opposites of these?

Euthyphro: Very much so.

8a

Socrates: Yes, but according to you, the same things are regarded as just by some gods but unjust by others, and because they disagree on these issues, they quarrel and fight with one another. Is this not so?

Euthyphro: This is so.

Socrates: Therefore, it seems that the same things are hated by the gods and are loved by them, and what is god-hated and what is god-loved would be the same.

Euthyphro: So it seems.

Socrates: Then by this argument, the same thing would be both holy and unholy, Euthyphro.

Euthyphro: Quite likely.

8b

Socrates: In that case, you did not answer the question I asked you, marvellous one, for I was not asking what is at once both holy and unholy, which would, it seems, be that which is god-loved and that which is god-hated. And so, Euthyphro, it would be no surprise if, in punishing your father as you are doing now, you are doing something that is loved by Zeus but hated by Cronus and Uranus; loved by Hephaestus but hated by Hera; and if any other gods differ with one another on this issue, the same considerations apply.

Euthyphro: But in my opinion, Socrates, none of the gods differ with one another on this issue: that a man who kills someone unjustly need not pay the penalty.

Socrates: But, Euthyphro, in the case of us humans, have you ever heard anyone arguing that a man who has killed someone unjustly, or performs any other unjust action whatsoever, should not pay a penalty?

8c

Euthyphro: Why, they never stop arguing over these issues, especially in the law courts. Indeed, having performed all sorts of injustices, people do and say anything at all to avoid a penalty.

Socrates: Yes, Euthyphro, but do they also admit that they have acted unjustly, and despite this admission, claim nevertheless that they should not pay a penalty?

Euthyphro: No, they do not do that at all.

Socrates: Then they do not do or say anything at all. Indeed, I think they would not dare to assert or to argue that they should not pay a penalty, if in fact they have acted unjustly. No, I think they deny that they have acted unjustly. Is this so?

Euthyphro: That is true.

8d

Socrates: So they do not argue that the person who commits injustice should not pay a penalty. They surely argue, instead, over who the wrongdoer is, what he did, and when.

Euthyphro: That is true.

Socrates: Do not the same considerations also apply to the gods, if they do indeed quarrel about justice and injustice, as you maintain, and one side claims that the other is acting unjustly, while the other side denies it? But this much is certain, my friend, no one, neither god nor human, would dare to suggest that a person who acts unjustly should not pay a penalty.

Euthyphro: Yes, Socrates, what you are saying is true, on the whole.

Socrates: Yes, I think those who differ, be they humans or gods, if indeed gods do differ, differ over particular actions. When they differ over any action, some maintain that it was performed in a just manner, others that it was performed in an unjust manner. Isn't this so?

Euthyphro: Entirely so.

8e

Socrates: Come on then, dear Euthyphro, and instruct me so that I may become wiser. What evidence do you have that all the gods think that this man met his death unjustly, a man who committed murder whilst working as a day-labourer, who was tied up by the master of the murder victim, and who died prematurely on account of his bonds, before the master, who had tied him up, had found out from the legal expositor what he should do about him. Where is your evidence that it is actually right for a son to prosecute his father, and denounce him, on behalf of a person like that? Come on, try to demonstrate these points clearly to me, that all of the gods really do believe that this course of action is right, and if you prove this to me

adequately, I shall sing the praises of your wisdom unceasingly.

9b

Euthyphro: Well, that is surely no small task, Socrates, yet I should be able to demonstrate it to you very clearly.

Socrates: I understand. That is because you think that I am a slower learner than the jurors, since you will, of course, prove to them that these actions are unjust, and that all of the gods hate such actions as these.

Euthyphro: Very clearly, Socrates, if they will only listen to what I say.

Socrates: They will listen alright, Euthyphro, provided they think you are speaking well. But while you were speaking something occurred to me, and I am thinking to myself, “If Euthyphro were to teach me, comprehensively, that all the gods regard a death like this one to be unjust, what more have I learned from Euthyphro as to what exactly holiness and unholiness are? Yes, this particular action would, it seems, be god-hated, but it turned out earlier that what is holy and what is not are not defined by this, for what is god-hated proved also to be god-loved.” So if you like, Euthyphro, I will grant you this: let all the gods think it unjust, and let them all hate it.

But what about this correction we have just introduced into the argument, according to which whatever all the gods hate is unholy, and whatever they all love is holy, and whatever some love and others hate is neither or both. Would you like us now to define what is holy and what is unholy in this way?

9d

Euthyphro: Is there any reason not to, Socrates?

Socrates: In my case no, Euthyphro, but in your own case, you should decide whether adopting this hypothesis is the easiest

way for you to teach me what you promised.

9c

Euthyphro: Well, I would say that what is holy is what all the gods love, and its opposite, what all the gods hate, is unholy.

Socrates: Should we also investigate whether this formulation is correct, Euthyphro? Or should we leave it, and accept our own or other people's assertions just like that, agreeing that this is the case just because somebody says so? Or should we consider what the speaker means?

Euthyphro: We should consider that. However, in my view, this is now a good formulation.

10a

Socrates: Good man. We shall know better soon enough. Yes, think about this. Is the holy loved by the gods because it is holy, or is it holy because it is loved?

Euthyphro: I do not understand what you are saying, Socrates.

Socrates: Then I shall try to speak with greater clarity. We say that something is carried and something carries, something is led and something leads, something is seen and something sees. And in all these cases, do you understand that there are differences between them, and the way in which they differ?

Euthyphro: I think I understand.

Socrates: And is there something that is loved, and is that different from that which loves?

Euthyphro: Of course.

10b

Socrates: Then, tell me whether something that is carried is what it is because it is being carried, or for some other reason?

Euthyphro: No, that is the reason.

Socrates: And something that is led is what it is because it is being led, and something that is seen is what it is because it is being seen.

Euthyphro: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: So, it is not because it is a seen thing that it is seen. It is the other way around: because it is seen it is a seen thing. Nor is it because it is a thing led that it is led. No, because it is led it is a thing led. Nor is it because it is a thing carried that it is carried. No, because it is carried it is a thing carried. So Euthyphro, is it obvious what I wish to say? What I mean is this. If anything becomes, or is affected, it is not because it is a thing that becomes that it becomes. No, because it becomes it is a thing that becomes. Nor is it because it is a thing affected that it is affected. No, because it is affected it is a thing affected. Do you agree that this is so?

10c

Euthyphro: I do.

Socrates: Now, is not that which is loved either something that is becoming, or something that is being affected by something?

Euthyphro: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And this case is like the previous cases. It is not because it is a thing loved that it is loved by those who love it. No, because it is loved it is a thing that is loved.

10d

Euthyphro: Necessarily.

Socrates: Well then, what do we say about what is holy, Euthyphro? Is it not loved by all the gods, according to your argument?

Euthyphro: Yes.

Socrates: So, is this because it is holy, or for some other reason?

Euthyphro: No, that is the reason.

Socrates: So, because it is holy it is loved. It is not the case that it is loved and for that reason is holy?

Euthyphro: It seems so.

Socrates: And yet, because something is loved by the gods, it is a thing that is loved and is god-loved.

Euthyphro: Of course.

Socrates: Therefore, what is god-loved is not holy, Euthyphro, nor is the holy god-loved, as you maintain. They are different from one another.

Euthyphro: How so, Socrates?

10e

Socrates: Because we agree that what is holy is loved because it is holy, and it is not because it is loved that it is holy. Is this so?

Euthyphro: Yes.

Socrates: And yet, what is god-loved is beloved of the gods by reason of their very love. But the reason it is loved is not that it is god-loved.

Euthyphro: That is true.

Socrates: But dear Euthyphro, if what is god-loved and what is holy were the same, then if what is holy was loved because of being holy, what is god-loved too would be loved because of being god-loved. And if, on the other hand, what is god-loved was god-loved because of being loved by the gods, what is holy too would be holy because of being loved. But you can now see that these two are opposites. They are completely different from one another. For one is a loved thing because it is loved, while the other is a loved thing, and is loved for that reason. And Euthyphro, when I asked what precisely the holy is, it seems you were not willing to disclose its essence to me, but

only to describe something it undergoes, that what is holy is affected as follows: it is loved by all the gods. But you have not yet said what it actually is. So if you please, do not hide this from me, but tell me again from the beginning what precisely the holy is, regardless of whether it is loved by the gods or whatever else happens to it, for we shall not argue over that. Just state what holiness and unholiness are, and do not hold back.

11b

Euthyphro: But Socrates, I do not know how to tell you what I have in mind. For anything we propose always wanders about somehow and will not stay where we put it.

Socrates: These pronouncements of yours, Euthyphro, seem to be like the works of my own ancestor, Daedalus,⁴ and if I was the one who had proposed them and set them down, you would probably have mocked me over my kinship to that man, because my verbal formulations run away and refuse to remain where someone puts them. But now, of course, the hypotheses are yours, so some alternative mockery is called for since they refuse to remain in place for you, as you can see for yourself.

11d

Euthyphro: But I think the pronouncements deserve more or less the same mockery, Socrates, for I am not the one who set them in motion so that they do not remain in the same place. No, it seems to me that you are the ‘Daedalus’, since if it were up to me they would have remained as they were.

Socrates: Perhaps, my friend, I have become cleverer at the craft than that ancestor of mine, to this extent: while he only made his own works unstable, it seems I do this to my own and to other people’s too. And, indeed, what is most delightful about the skill in my case is that I am wise against my will, for I would have preferred that my own pronouncements be stable, fixed and unmoving, rather than possess the wisdom of Daedalus and

the wealth of Tantalus⁵ too. But enough of all this. Since you yourself seem to be indolent, I will join you in your desire to instruct me about what is holy. Do not give up yet. Think about this: is everything that is holy necessarily just?

11e

Euthyphro: I think so.

12a

Socrates: And is everything that is just, also holy? Or is what is holy all just, while what is just is not all holy, part of it being holy and part something else?

Euthyphro: Socrates, I cannot follow you.

Socrates: And yet you are younger than me, and no less wise, for that. But as I said, your wealth of wisdom makes you indolent. So exert yourself, blessed man, for it is not difficult to understand what I mean. Indeed, I am saying the opposite of the poet who wrote these lines:

*Zeus the creator, who made all this, you shrink from reviling,
For when there is fear there is also reverence.*⁶

Now, I disagree with this poet. Shall I tell you why?

12b

Euthyphro: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: I do not think that ‘when there is fear there is also reverence’, because I think that many people who fear disease and poverty, and lots of other things like these, are afraid, yet they are not at all ashamed of the things they fear. Is this not how it seems to you too?

Euthyphro: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: But I do think that when there is reverence, there is also fear. Indeed, is there anyone who is ashamed of something, feels shame, and is not at the same time fearful, and afraid of a

reputation for wickedness?

12c

Euthyphro: Yes, he is afraid.

Socrates: So, it is not right to say that ‘when there is fear there is also reverence’. On the contrary, when there is reverence there is also fear, and yet when there is fear there is not reverence in every case, for I think that fear is more extensive than reverence. Indeed, reverence is a part of fear, just as odd is part of number, and so it is not the case that when there is number there is also the odd, and yet where there is the odd there is also number. So I presume you follow me now.

Euthyphro: Yes, certainly.

12d

Socrates: Well, this is more or less what I meant by the earlier question. When there is justice, is there also holiness? Or when there is holiness, is there also justice? While conversely, when there is justice, there is not holiness in every case, because holiness is a part of justice? Should we say this, or do you think otherwise?

Euthyphro: No, let us say this. I think you are expressing this correctly.

Socrates: Then, take note of the next issue, for if holiness is part of justice, we should, it seems, find out what part it would be. Now, suppose you had asked me about something we have just discussed, number, for instance, what part of number is the even part, and what kind of number it is, I would reply that it has equal sides rather than unequal sides.⁷ Is that what you think?

Euthyphro: It is.

12e

Socrates: So you should now also attempt to teach me, in this way, the part of justice that is holy, so that I may tell Meletus

not to wrong me anymore, or to prosecute me for impiety, as I have now received adequate instruction from you about what is pious and holy, and what is not.

13a

Euthyphro: Well, Socrates, it seems to me that the part of justice that is pious and holy is the part that deals with care of the gods, while the remaining part of justice deals with care of human beings.

Socrates: And, in my view, you have expressed that well, Euthyphro. But there is one minor detail still outstanding, for I do not yet understand what the care you are referring to actually is. For I presume you do not mean that the sort of care that deals with the gods is just like the care that deals with anything else. Yes, is this not how we speak? We say, for instance, that not everyone knows how to care for horses, only the skilled horse-trainer. Is this so?

Euthyphro: Very much so.

Socrates: For horse-training is, presumably, the care of horses?

Euthyphro: Yes.

13b

Socrates: Nor, for that matter, does everyone know how to care for dogs, only the dog-handler?

Euthyphro: Quite so.

Socrates: For dog-handling is, presumably, the care of dogs?

Euthyphro: Yes.

Socrates: And ox-herding of oxen?

Euthyphro: Very much so.

Socrates: And holiness and piety are the care of gods, Euthyphro. Is this what you mean?

Euthyphro: I do.

Socrates: And does not all care bring about the same outcome? Something like this: it is directed to some good or some benefit of whatever is cared for. For instance, you can see that horses cared for by horse-training are benefited and become better. Do you not think so?

Euthyphro: I do.

13c

Socrates: And dogs are, presumably, benefited by dog-handling, oxen by ox-herding, and the same applies in all other cases. Or do you think that the care aims to harm whatever it cares for?

Euthyphro: By Zeus, I do not.

Socrates: Does it aim to benefit it then?

Euthyphro: How could it do otherwise?

Socrates: Now, is holiness too, being a care of the gods, also a benefit to the gods, and does it make the gods better? And would you accept that you make any of the gods better whenever you do anything holy?

Euthyphro: By Zeus, I would not.

13d

Socrates: No, I did not think that was what you meant either, Euthyphro, far from it. And that is why I asked you what exactly you meant by this care of the gods. I was assuming you did not mean anything like this.

Euthyphro: And you are right, Socrates. I do not mean anything like this.

Socrates: So be it. But in that case, what care of the gods would holiness be?

Euthyphro: It is the care, Socrates, which servants give their masters.

Socrates: I understand. It would, it seems, be some service to the gods.

Euthyphro: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: What about the service to physicians? What product does this service help to produce? Do you not think it is health?

Euthyphro: I do.

13e

Socrates: What about service to shipbuilders? What product does this service help to produce?

14a

Euthyphro: Obviously, Socrates, it is a ship.

Socrates: And in the case of housebuilders, presumably it is a house?

Euthyphro: Yes.

Socrates: Then tell me, best of men, in the case of service to the gods, what product would this service help to produce? You must know the answer since you declare that your knowledge of matters divine is superior to that of anyone else.

Euthyphro: And what I say is true, Socrates.

Socrates: Then tell me, by Zeus, what glorious product do the gods produce, using us as their servants?

Euthyphro: Many and beautiful things, Socrates.

Socrates: Yes, so do the generals, my friend, but it is easy nevertheless to sum it all up by saying that they bring about victory in war. Isn't this so?

Euthyphro: Of course.

Socrates: And farmers too produce many and beautiful things, but nevertheless what they produce is, in summary, food from the earth.

Euthyphro: Certainly.

Socrates: Yes, but what about the many beautiful things that the gods produce? What, in summary, is their product?

14b

Euthyphro: Well, I told you a little earlier, Socrates, that to understand precisely how matters stand in all these cases is a major undertaking. Yet I can say, in general terms, that if someone knows how to do and say what is gratifying to the gods, by praying and offering sacrifices, these actions are the holy ones, and such actions safeguard the things of private homes and the common things of entire cities. But the opposite of what gratifies them is impious, and this overturns and destroys everything.

14c

Socrates: If you had wanted to, Euthyphro, you could have given me the summary I asked you for much more briefly. But you are not eager to instruct me, that is obvious. In fact, right now you turned aside at the very point where, had you answered, I might by now have learned about holiness from you quite adequately. But now the lover needs to follow the beloved, wherever he may lead. So again, what do you say the holy and holiness is? Is it not some sort of knowledge of sacrificing and praying?

Euthyphro: It is.

Socrates: Is not sacrifice giving to the gods, and prayer asking of the gods?

Euthyphro: Very much so, Socrates.

14d

Socrates: So on this formulation, holiness would be knowledge of asking of and giving to the gods.

Euthyphro: You have understood perfectly what I have said, Socrates.

Socrates: That is because I am eager for your wisdom, my friend, and I give it my full attention so that nothing you say may be lost. But tell me, what is this service to the gods? Are you saying that it consists in asking of them and giving to them?

Euthyphro: I am.

Socrates: And would not the right manner of asking be to ask of them what we need from them?

Euthyphro: That is it.

14e

Socrates: Then again, is not the right manner of giving to give them in return whatever they happen to need from us? Indeed, giving anyone something they do not need would, presumably, not require any skill.

Euthyphro: That is true, Socrates.

Socrates: Then, Euthyphro, holiness would be a skill which involved gods and men trading with one another.

Euthyphro: Yes, call it trade if it pleases you to do so.

15a

Socrates: Well, nothing pleases me unless it happens to be true. But tell me, what benefit do the gods derive from the gifts they obtain from us? What they give us is obvious to everyone, for anything good that we have, they have given us. But how are they benefited by what they obtain from us? Or do we gain such an advantage over them from the trading that we get all good things from them, while they get nothing from us?

Euthyphro: But Socrates, do you think the gods derive benefit from what they obtain from us?

Socrates: But Euthyphro, what exactly would these gifts we bestow upon the gods be?

Euthyphro: What else do you think, except honour, reverence and, as I said earlier, gratification.

15b

Socrates: So, the holy is gratifying to the gods, Euthyphro, but is it not beneficial to them, or loved by them?

Euthyphro: I really think it is the most beloved thing of all.

Socrates: So once again it seems that the holy is what is loved by the gods.

Euthyphro: Very much so.

Socrates: And once you say this, will you be surprised then to find that our propositions are inconstant and go walking? And will you accuse me of being the Daedalus who makes them walk, when you yourself are far more skilled than Daedalus, and can make them go around in a circle? Or can you not see that our argument has gone around in a circle and arrived back in the same place? For I presume you remember that, in our previous discussion, it was evident to us that what is holy and what is god-loved are not the same, but differ from one another. Or do you not remember?

15c

Euthyphro: I do.

Socrates: Well, do you not realise now that you are saying that what is loved by the gods is holy? But this happens not to be god-loved, does it not?

Euthyphro: Certainly.

Socrates: In that case, either our earlier agreement was incorrect or, if we were right then, we are wrong now.

Euthyphro: So it seems.

15d

Socrates: Then, we must consider what holiness is once more from the beginning, since I am not willing to give up until I have learned this. But please, do not be contemptuous towards me. Just give this your fullest attention in every way, and tell me the truth now. For you know the truth if any man knows it, and, just like Proteus,⁸ you are not to be let go until you tell me. For if you did not know full well what is holy and also what is unholy, there is no possibility that you would ever have undertaken to prosecute an old man, your own father, for murder, on behalf of a day-labourer. No, you would have feared the gods too much to take the risk that you might be acting improperly. And you would have been ashamed before your fellow men too. But I am now quite aware that you think you know full well what is holy and what is not. So tell me, excellent Euthyphro, and please do not hide what you think it is.

15e

Euthyphro: Well, some other time, Socrates, for I am rushing somewhere else now and it is time for me to go.

16a

Socrates: What are you doing my friend? You are leaving, casting me down from the great hope I had that, having learned what is holy and what is not from you, I would escape the charge of Meletus by showing him that, through Euthyphro, I had now become wise in divine matters, and that I no longer make rash pronouncements and innovations about them because of my ignorance, and that I would live a better life in all other respects from now on.

NOTES

1. The Lyceum was a temple in Athens dedicated to Apollo Lyceus, which later became a site for public exercise. It is perhaps best known as the location of Aristotle's Peripatetic school, founded in 344.
2. The Royal Stoa, an administrative building located in the Athenian Agora, was where Socrates was formally sent forward for trial.
3. Demes were small administrative areas within the city-state of Athens.
4. Daedalus, a figure in Greek mythology, was a skilled architect and craftsman. He was said to have sculpted figures so real that they appeared to live and move. Socrates' father was a sculptor, hence his claim to a familial connection.
5. Tantalus is best known for his punishment in the underworld. His wealth derived from mines in Phrygia.
6. These lines are of unknown authorship.
7. Plato is construing the concepts of odd number and even number here in terms of certain types of triangles: the scalene triangle, which has unequal sides, is odd, and the isosceles triangle, which has equal sides, is even.
8. *Odyssey* iv.382 ff.

Gorgias

ΓΟΡΓΙΑΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

CALLICLES an Athenian politician

SOCRATES of Alopece, son of Sophroniscus

CHAEREPHON a close friend of Socrates

GORGAS a renowned rhetorician

POLUS a rhetorician, student of Gorgias

scene: outside a public building where Gorgias has given a display and taken questions

447a

Callicles: Well, Socrates, you know the saying, ‘When going to war or a battle, it may be too late to join in!’

Socrates: Oh! Does this mean that a banquet has ended and we are late?

Callicles: Yes, a very elegant banquet indeed, for Gorgias¹ gave us an exhibition² of great variety and beauty a short time ago.

Socrates: Actually, it was all the fault of Chaerephon³ here for forcing me to spend so long in the Agora.⁴

447b

Chaerephon: It does not matter, Socrates. I shall also solve the problem. Yes, Gorgias is a friend of mine, so he will give the exhibition for you now if you like, or some other time if you prefer.

Callicles: What’s this, Chaerephon? Does Socrates want to hear Gorgias?

Chaerephon: That is the very reason we are here.

Callicles: In that case, come and visit me at my house whenever you wish. Yes, Gorgias is staying with me, and he will give the exhibition for you.

447c

Socrates: It is kind of you to offer, Callicles, but would he agree to converse with us? In fact, I want to find out from him what power this skill of his possesses, and what it is that he proclaims and teaches. He may present the other exhibition on some other occasion, as you suggest.

Callicles: There's nothing like asking the man himself, Socrates. Actually, this was one part of his exhibition, for a moment ago he called upon anyone who was inside to ask any question they wished, and he said that he would answer them all.

Socrates: That is wonderful news! You ask him, Chaerephon.

Chaerephon: What should I ask?

Socrates: Ask him who he is.

447d

Chaerephon: What do you mean?

Socrates: For example, if he happened to be a maker of shoes, I presume he would answer that he is a cobbler. Do you understand what I mean?

448a

Chaerephon: I understand and I shall ask. Tell me, Gorgias, is Callicles⁵ here speaking the truth, that you proclaim that you will answer whatever question anyone may ask you?

Gorgias: It is true, Chaerephon. Yes, indeed, I made that very announcement, and I can tell you that no one has yet asked me a new question, not for many years.

Chaerephon: Then I expect you will find this easy to answer.

Gorgias: Now is your chance, Chaerephon, to put that to the test.

Polus: Come on, Chaerephon, why don't you put me to the test instead? For I think that Gorgias is quite tired since he has just been doing a lot of talking.

Chaerephon: What is this, Polus?⁶ Do you think that you can give better answers than Gorgias?

Polus: What difference does that make, as long as they are good enough for you?

Chaerephon: None. Anyway, since you want to, you should answer.

Polus: Ask.

Chaerephon: My question is this. If Gorgias happened to be knowledgeable in the skill that his brother Herodicus possesses, what would we be right to call him? The same thing we call his brother?

448b

Polus: Certainly.

Chaerephon: So, if we called him a physician we would have described him accurately.

Polus: Yes.

Chaerephon: Yes, and if he practised the skill of Aristophon, the son of Aglauphon, or his brother,⁷ what would we be right to call him?

Polus: Obviously a painter.

Chaerephon: And now, what would be the correct title to give Gorgias, in view of the skill in which he is knowledgeable?

448c

Polus: Chaerephon, humanity possesses numerous skills that have been discovered in a practical way through experience. For practicality makes our time on earth proceed on the basis of skill, impracticality on the basis of chance. Various people partake of these particular skills in various ways, and the best partake of the best. And Gorgias here is one of the best, and he practises the most sublime skill of all.

448d

Socrates: Gorgias, when it comes to speeches, Polus appears to have been equipped well and truly. And yet he is not keeping the promise he made to Chaerephon.

Gorgias: What exactly do you mean, Socrates?

Socrates: He appears to me not to have answered the question at all.

Gorgias: Then you should question him, if you'd like to.

Socrates: If you yourself were willing to answer, I would much prefer to ask you. In fact, it is evident to me from what Polus has said that he has studied so-called rhetoric more than dialectic.

Polus: Why is that, Socrates?

Socrates: Because, Polus, when Chaerephon asked you what skill Gorgias knows about, you praised this skill of his as if someone were criticising it, but you did not give an answer as to what it is.

448e

Polus: Did I not answer that it is the most sublime skill?

449a

Socrates: You did, indeed. But nobody asked you what Gorgias' skill is like, but what it is and what we should call Gorgias. Just as Chaerephon set out questions for you earlier and you answered him clearly and concisely, so should you speak now and say what this skill is and what we should call Gorgias. Or better yet, Gorgias, tell us yourself what you should be called on account of your knowledge, of what skill.

Gorgias: The skill of rhetoric, Socrates.

Socrates: So, you should be called a rhetorician?

Gorgias: Yes, Socrates, but I am a good one, if you are prepared to call me what, in Homer's phrase, 'I boast myself to be'!⁸

Socrates: I am quite prepared to do so.

Gorgias: Then call me that.

449b

Socrates: And should we say that you are able to turn other people into rhetoricians?

Gorgias: Yes, I profess to do just that, not only here but in other places too.

Socrates: Now, Gorgias, would you agree to continue our conversation as we are now doing – one person asking questions, the other answering – and defer to another occasion any lengthy speeches such as the one with which Polus began? And be true to your promise, but please answer each question briefly.

449c

Gorgias: Well, Socrates, some answers demand that long speeches be made. However, I shall try anyway to be as brief as possible. And, indeed, what is more, one of my claims is that no one can express himself as concisely as I on the same issues.

Socrates: That is what is needed, Gorgias. Just give me an exhibition of this concise form of speech and defer the lengthy form to another occasion.

Gorgias: That's what I shall do, and you will say that you have heard no one speak more concisely.

449d

Socrates: Come on, then. You say that you are knowledgeable in the skill of rhetoric and can make a rhetorician of someone else. With which of the things that are, is rhetoric concerned? For instance, weaving is concerned with the manufacture of garments, isn't it?

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: And isn't music concerned with composing melodies?

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: By Hera, Gorgias, I am delighted with these answers. You are answering as briefly as you possibly could.

Gorgias: Yes, Socrates, I really think that I am doing quite well.

Socrates: Well said. Come now, answer me in the same way about rhetoric. About which of the things that are, is rhetoric the knowledge?

449e

Gorgias: About speeches.

Socrates: What sort of speeches, Gorgias? Speeches that show sick people the regimen by which they may become healthy?

Gorgias: No.

Socrates: So, rhetoric is not concerned with all speeches anyway.

Gorgias: Of course not.

Socrates: And yet it does make people capable of speaking.

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: And to understand what they are speaking about?

Gorgias: Inevitably.

450a

Socrates: Now, does medicine, which we just mentioned, make someone capable of understanding and speaking about those who are ill?

Gorgias: It must.

Socrates: So, medicine, it seems, is also concerned with speeches.

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: Speeches concerning illnesses?

Gorgias: Certainly.

Socrates: And isn't gymnastic also concerned with speeches about the good or bad condition of the body?

Gorgias: Entirely so.

Socrates: And, indeed, Gorgias, the same applies to the other skills. Each of them is concerned with speeches relating to the subject matter of that particular skill.

Gorgias: So it appears.

450b

Socrates: Then why don't you ever refer to the other skills as rhetorical, since they are concerned with speeches, if, in fact, you call the skill that is concerned with speeches rhetoric?

Gorgias: Because, Socrates, the other skills are almost entirely concerned with knowledge of practical dexterity and activities of that sort, whereas no aspect of rhetoric involves practical dexterity. Rather, its action and efficacy work entirely through words. For these reasons, I regard the skill of rhetoric as being concerned with speeches, and that, I say, is a correct account.

450c

Socrates: Now, do I really understand the sort of skill that you wish to call it? But perhaps I shall come to know this more clearly. So, answer me this. We do possess skills, is this not so?

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: Well, I think that the vast majority of skills involve practical dexterity and very little speaking, and some involve none at all because the objective of the skill may be attained through silence, as in the case of painting and sculpting, and numerous other skills. I think you are saying that rhetoric is not concerned with skills such as these. Is this so?

Gorgias: You have understood my meaning very well, Socrates.

450d

Socrates: And yet there is a different set of skills that operates entirely through speech, and requires almost no action or very little. Take arithmetic for instance, or calculation, geometry, or even draughts-playing, and numerous other skills. Some of these involve almost as much speech as activity, but in many such cases, most, if not all, of their entire activity and their efficacy is based upon words. And I think it is a skill belonging to such activities as these that you say is rhetoric.

Gorgias: True.

450e

Socrates: But I do not think you wish to refer to any particular one of these skills as the skill of rhetoric, even though the formulation you used implies that a skill that is effected through words is rhetoric. Indeed, someone who wanted to contrive difficulties in these arguments might respond, “So, Gorgias, are you saying that arithmetic is rhetoric?” But I do not think you are saying that either arithmetic or geometry is rhetoric.

Gorgias: Indeed, Socrates, your thinking is correct, and you rightly understand my meaning.

451a

Socrates: Come on, now. You should also work through the answer to the question in the way that I asked it. Since rhetoric happens to be one of those skills that relies for the most part upon speech, and since there are also other skills of this sort, try to state what words the efficacy of rhetoric is concerned with. Words about what? For instance, if someone were to ask me about any of the skills I mentioned just now, “Socrates, what is the skill of arithmetic?”, I would tell him, as you did just now, that it is one of the skills that is effected by means of speech. And if he were to ask again, “Speech about what?”, I would reply that it is speech about odd and even numbers, and the extent of

each. And if he were to go on and ask, “What skill do you refer to as ‘calculation’?”, I would say that it is one of the skills that is effective entirely through speech. And if he were also to ask, “About what?”, I would say, as the recorders in the Assembly might say, that for the most part calculation is just like arithmetic for it is concerned with the same thing, the odd and the even. Yet they differ insofar as calculation considers the quantity associated with the odd and the even, both in relation to themselves and in relation to one another. And if someone asked about astronomy because I said that it is effective entirely through speech, and said, “What are the pronouncements of astronomy concerned with?”, I would reply that they deal with the motion of the stars and sun and moon, and their speed relative to one another.

451c

Gorgias: Well, you are right to say all that anyway, Socrates.

451d

Socrates: Then you should try this too, Gorgias. Rhetoric is one of those skills that operates and is effective through speech. Is this so?

Gorgias: That’s what it is.

Socrates: Can you explain what it is concerned with? Among things that are, what is it that the particular words employed by rhetoric are concerned with?

Gorgias: With the most important and sublime of human affairs, Socrates.

451e

Socrates: But, Gorgias, this too is ambiguous, and you are still not saying anything that is clear. In fact, I am sure you have heard the round that men sing at parties in which they make a list in song, according to which it is best to be healthy, second best to be beautiful, and third best, according to the composer

of the song, is to be wealthy by honest means.

Gorgias: Yes, I have heard this, but why are you referring to it?

452a

Socrates: What if artificers of whatever is praised by the composer of the song were to stand before you right now? I mean a physician, a trainer, a businessman. First the physician would say, “Socrates, Gorgias is deceiving you. This skill of his is not concerned with the most important good of humankind. Mine is.” Now, if I were to ask him, “Who are you to say so?” he would probably say that he is a physician. “What do you mean?” I would say. “Is the product of your skill the most important good?” “Of course it is,” he would probably reply. “Socrates, the product of my skill is health, and what good is more important to humanity than health?”

And if the trainer spoke next and said, “I too would be surprised, Socrates, if Gorgias was able to show you that there is a greater good in this skill of his than I could show in mine,” I would in turn ask him, “Who are you, my man, and what is your job?” And he would reply, “I am a trainer and my job is to make men’s bodies strong and fair.” After the trainer, the businessman would say, I imagine, with total contempt for everyone else, “Think about this, Socrates. Does any good seem more important to you than wealth, whether it belongs to Gorgias or anyone else at all?” We might then say, “Oh! Are you the artificer of this?” and he would say, “Yes.” “Who are you?” we would ask. “A businessman.” And we shall say, “Well then, do you regard wealth as the greatest good for us humans?” “Of course it is,” he will say. And we would reply, “And yet Gorgias here is arguing that the skill he possesses is the cause of greater good than yours.” Of course, he would then ask, “And what is this good? Put that question to Gorgias.” So come on, Gorgias, you should regard yourself as

being questioned by these people and by me. Tell me what it is that you describe as the greatest good to humanity, a good of which you are the artificer.

452d

Gorgias: What it is in truth, Socrates, is a great good, and the cause on the one hand of freedom for humanity itself, and at the same time of dominion over others, for each person in his own city.

Socrates: And what do you call this good?

452e

Gorgias: I call it the ability to persuade by means of speeches, to persuade jurors in a law court, councillors in the Council, assembly men in the Assembly, or anyone else at a gathering convened for political purposes. In fact, in virtue of this power, the physician will be your slave and the trainer will be your slave, and this businessman will turn out to be making money for someone else and not for himself – for you, actually, the man with the power to speak and persuade crowds of people.

453a

Socrates: I think you have now come as close as possible to showing what you consider rhetoric to be. And if I understand at all, you are asserting that rhetoric is an artificer of persuasion, and its entire function and summation consists in this. Or can you say that rhetoric is able to do anything more than produce persuasion in the soul of those who hear it?

Gorgias: Not at all, Socrates. I think you are defining it quite adequately. Yes, that is the summation of rhetoric.

Socrates: Listen, Gorgias. You need to appreciate something. I am convinced that if anyone ever converses with anyone else with the intention of understanding precisely what it is that the discussion is concerned with, I am one of those people, and I count you among them too.

453b

Gorgias: What point are you making, Socrates?

Socrates: I shall tell you now. You need to be fully aware that when you speak of this persuasion produced by rhetoric, I do not know what exactly it is, or what sort of issues it relates to. And yet I do have my suspicions somehow, based upon what I think you are saying it is, and what it relates to. Nevertheless, I shall ask you what precisely you mean by the persuasion produced by rhetoric, and what subjects it relates to. Now, since I have my suspicions, why do I proceed to ask you rather than telling you myself? Well, it is not for your sake, but for the sake of the argument, so that it may proceed in this way to render the issue we are discussing as evident to us as possible. You should consider whether you regard my questioning as justified. For instance, suppose I were to ask you what sort of painter Zeuxis is,⁹ and you were to reply that he painted animals, wouldn't I be justified in asking what sort of animals he paints, and where?

453c

Gorgias: Entirely so.

Socrates: And is the reason that there are other painters who paint numerous other animals?

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: But if no one else besides Zeuxis did any painting, would your response have been adequate?

Gorgias: Of course.

453d

Socrates: Come on then, and speak about rhetoric. Do you think that rhetoric alone produces persuasion, or do other skills do this too? I mean, does anyone who teaches any subject whatsoever engage in persuasion or not?

Gorgias: He does, of course. He is more persuasive than anyone else.

Socrates: Let us talk again about the same skills we referred to a moment ago. Doesn't arithmetic, and the person who is arithmetical, teach us whatever relates to number?

Gorgias: Entirely so.

Socrates: And doesn't he also persuade?

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: So, arithmetic is also an artificer of persuasion?

Gorgias: So it appears.

453e

Socrates: Therefore, if someone asks us what kind of persuasion it is, and what it relates to, I presume we would answer him that it is instructive persuasion concerning the extent of the even and the odd. And for all of the other skills we mentioned just now, we shall be able to show that they are artificers of persuasion, what sort it is, and what it relates to. Is this so?

454a

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: So, rhetoric is not the sole artificer of persuasion.

Gorgias: That's true.

Socrates: Then since it is not the only skill that performs this function, but others do so too, we would be justified in questioning once more anyone who asserts this, just as we put a further question in relation to painting. Of what kind of persuasion is rhetoric a skill, and concerning what? Or don't you think it is right to ask this question once more?

454b

Gorgias: I do.

Socrates: Well, Gorgias, since that is what you think, you should answer the question.

Gorgias: Socrates, I am referring to the sort of persuasion that occurs in courts of law and in other gatherings, as I said earlier, and it concerns matters that are just and unjust.

Socrates: Yes, Gorgias, and I suspected that this was the sort of persuasion you meant, and that this was its concern. But I do not want you to be surprised if I ask you another question like this quite soon, the sort of question that seems obvious but which I repeat in any case. For, as I say, I am not asking for your sake but for the sake of the completion of the argument, so that we do not get into the habit of snatching at one another's pronouncements through guesswork. Instead, you should come to your own conclusions in whatever manner you wish on the basis of the hypothesis.

454c

Gorgias: Yes, I think that's the right way to do it, Socrates.

Socrates: Come on then, and let us consider this. Do you use the expression 'to have learned'?

Gorgias: I use it.

Socrates: And 'to have believed'?

454d

Gorgias: I do.

Socrates: Now, do you think 'to have learned' and 'to have believed', and 'learning' and 'belief' are the same or different?

Gorgias: In my view anyway, Socrates, they are different.

Socrates: Yes, you are right to think so and you may confirm it as follows. For if someone were to ask you, "Gorgias, is there true belief and false belief?" you would agree, I presume.

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: What about this? Is there true and false knowledge?

Gorgias: Not at all.

Socrates: So it is obvious that they are not the same.

Gorgias: What you say is true.

454e

Socrates: And yet those who have learned have been persuaded, and so have those who believe.

Gorgias: This is so.

Socrates: So, do you want us to posit two forms of persuasion, one furnishing belief without knowing, and the other furnishing knowledge?

Gorgias: Entirely so.

Socrates: In that case, which persuasion does rhetoric produce in law courts and other gatherings in relation to matters of justice and injustice? Is it the sort from which believing arises without the knowing, or the sort from which the knowing arises?

Gorgias: It is obvious, surely, that it is the sort from which believing arises.

455a

Socrates: So, rhetoric is, it seems, the artificer of belief-based rather than instructive persuasion about the just and the unjust.

Gorgias: Yes.

455b

Socrates: So, the rhetorician is not instructive towards law courts and the other gatherings with regard to matters of justice and injustice, he is merely persuasive. For, of course, he would not be able to instruct a gathering of that sort in a limited time on such important matters.

Gorgias: Of course not.

Socrates: Come on then, let us look at what precisely we are saying about rhetoric. For I myself am unable to understand, as yet, what I am saying. Whenever there is a meeting in the city about the selection of physicians or shipbuilders, or some other category of artificers, that is not the occasion when the rhetorician will give advice, is it? For it is evident that in each of these selections, the most skilled person should be selected. Nor do they advise us when the subject is the construction of walls or the fitting out of harbours and dockyards. No, the architects advise us then. Again, when there is deliberation about the selection of generals or our formation against our enemies or the capture of territories, it is military men who give advice then, and not the rhetoricians. Or how would you describe deliberations of this kind, Gorgias? Indeed, since you say that you are yourself a rhetorician and can make rhetoricians of others, it would be worthwhile to find out about the details of this skill from you. And you should regard me too as someone who is concerned for your interests, for there may be someone inside who wishes to become a pupil of yours. I notice some, quite a number actually, and they would probably be embarrassed to question you. So, when you are being questioned by me, regard yourself as being questioned by them too: "What will be ours, Gorgias, if we consort with you? On what affairs of the city shall we be enabled to advise? Is it only about what is just and unjust, or also about the topics Socrates mentioned a moment ago?" Now, try to respond to them.

455d

Gorgias: Well, Socrates, I shall try to reveal the entire power of rhetoric to you in a clear manner. You led the way very nicely yourself. For you know, of course, that those dockyards and the walls of Athens and the fitting out of the harbours owe their origin to the advice of Themistocles, and the others to the

advice of Pericles, but not to the advice of artificers.¹⁰

455e

Socrates: Yes, Gorgias, that is what they say about Themistocles, and I heard Pericles myself when he advised us about the Middle Wall.¹¹

Gorgias: And whenever there is a decision of the kind you mentioned just now, you see that the rhetoricians are those who give advice and whose opinions prevail on these matters.

Socrates: Yes, these are the issues I wonder about, and for some time I have been asking what precisely the power of rhetoric is. For when I consider it in this way, its greatness appears to me as something supernatural.

456a

Gorgias: If only you knew all of it, Socrates, that it somehow incorporates all of the powers within itself! I'll give you strong evidence for this. On many occasions, I have gone along with my brother and with the other physicians to someone who was ill but was unwilling to swallow the medicine or submit to cutting or burning at the physician's hands. Now, the physicians were unable to persuade him, but I persuaded him by means of no other skill than rhetoric. And I also assert that if the physician and the rhetorician went to any city you care to name, and it was necessary to have a verbal contest in the Assembly, or some other meeting, as to which of them should be chosen as physician, the physician would not feature at all, but the one with the power to speak would be chosen, if he so wished. And if he were to compete against any other artificer whatsoever, the rhetorician would persuade people to choose himself rather than anyone else at all. For there is no issue on which the rhetorician could not speak more persuasively at a gathering than any other artificer. Now then, such is the power of this skill, and such is its extent.

However, Socrates, one should make use of rhetoric just as one uses any other competitive skill. And, indeed, no other competitive skill is learned in order to be used against the entire human race. Because one learns boxing and fighting, and fighting in full armour so as to be superior to friends and to enemies, one does not, on that account, strike one's friends or stab them or kill them. Nor, by Zeus, if someone has frequented a gymnasium, gets his body into good shape, becomes a skilled boxer, and then punches his father or mother or some family members or friends, should we, on that account, hate the trainers or the teachers of armour-fighting, and expel them from our cities? No, those men imparted the skill to others to be used in a just manner against enemies and miscreants, defensively, not on their own initiative. But the pupils pervert it and use their strength and skill in an improper manner.

Therefore, those who teach it are not corrupt, nor, on this account, is the skill either blameworthy or corrupt. No, I think the fault lies with those who do not use it properly. Now, the same argument also applies to rhetoric. The rhetorician has the power to oppose everyone and to speak on every topic, and so he is more persuasive before large gatherings on any issue he chooses, almost anything at all. However, he need not, on that account, be any more inclined to take away the reputation of physicians or other artificers just because he has the power to do so. Instead, as with any other competitive skill, he needs to use rhetoric justly. But in my view, if someone who has become a rhetorician acts unjustly by means of this power and this skill, we should not hate the person who taught him, and expel him from our cities. For that man imparted the knowledge to be used justly,

but the pupil used it in the opposite way. So, it is right to hate the one who used it improperly, and exile him or kill him, but not the one who taught him.

457c

Socrates: I imagine, Gorgias, that you, like me, have experience of a whole range of speeches, and that you have observed something about them – that the speakers are not easily capable of mutually defining the issues they are trying to discuss, and of learning and teaching themselves, and concluding their meeting upon that basis. Instead, when they dispute over something, and one says that the other is not speaking correctly or clearly, they become angry and they believe that the other is speaking from resentment towards them, from a thirst for victory, rather than pursuing the issue in front of them for discussion. And some of them end up behaving most disgracefully, engaging in slander, and saying and hearing such things as make even their audience angry on their own account, because they deemed such fellows worth listening to.

Well, why am I saying this? It is because I think that what you are now saying is neither entirely consistent nor consonant with what you first said about rhetoric. Yet I am afraid to refute you in case you assume that I am out for victory and my words are aimed at you rather than the issue and its elucidation. Now, if you are the sort of person that I am, I would gladly continue to question you, but otherwise I shall have done with it.

What sort of person am I? I am one of those who would gladly be refuted if I say anything untrue, and would gladly engage in refutation if someone else were to say something untrue, and yet I am no less averse to being refuted than to engaging in refutation. Indeed, I think that being refuted is a greater

good insofar as it is a greater good to be released oneself from the greatest evil, rather than releasing someone else. For I believe that nothing is so evil for a person as a false opinion on the issues with which our present discussion is concerned. So, if you claim to be someone of this sort, let us have a discussion, but if you think we should have done with it, let us bid the issue farewell now, and bring our discussion to an end.

458c

Gorgias: No, Socrates, I say that I myself am the sort of person you have described. However, we should probably take our audience into consideration too. Yes, I should tell you that a while ago, before you arrived, I gave numerous exhibitions to these people, and we are now likely to prolong this unduly if we engage in discussion. So, we should also consider their circumstances in case we are detaining some of them who wish to do something else.

Chaerephon: Socrates and Gorgias, listen for yourselves to the commotion from these men, who wish to hear anything you have to say. As for myself, I pray that I never become so busy that I would set aside such discussions as these, conducted in this manner, because it became more important to do something else.

458d

Callicles: Yes, by the gods, Chaerephon, I myself have been present at many discussions over the years, but I don't know if I have ever before been so delighted as I am now. Accordingly, if you wish to converse for the whole day, you will be doing me a favour anyway.

Socrates: And, indeed, Callicles, there is no impediment on my part as long as Gorgias is willing.

Gorgias: Well, Socrates, after all that it would be a disgrace for me to prove unwilling, since I was the one who announced that anyone could ask whatever they wanted. So, if this is how these people see it, proceed with the discussion and ask any question you want.

458e

Socrates: Then listen, Gorgias, to what surprised me in the statements that you made. Indeed, it is possible that what you say is correct, and I am not understanding you correctly. Do you say that you can make someone a rhetorician, if he wishes to learn from you?

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: So that he may be persuasive before a crowd, not teaching them but persuading them?

Gorgias: Entirely so.

459a

Socrates: And you also said just now that even on health matters, the rhetorician will be more persuasive than the physician.

Gorgias: Yes I did, before a crowd anyway.

Socrates: Does not 'before a crowd' mean 'before those who do not know'? For surely before those who know he would not be more persuasive than the physician.

Gorgias: What you say is true.

Socrates: And since he will be more persuasive than the physician, he turns out to be more persuasive than the one who knows.

Gorgias: Certainly.

Socrates: Although he is not a physician. Is this so?

Gorgias: Yes.

459b

Socrates: But the non-physician is, of course, not knowledgeable on matters of which the physician is knowledgeable.

Gorgias: Obviously.

Socrates: So, whenever the rhetorician is more persuasive than the physician, the person who does not know will be more persuasive than the person who knows, before those who do not know. Does this follow or does it not?

Gorgias: It follows from what went before, anyway.

Socrates: Therefore, in relation to all the other skills, the position of the rhetorician or rhetoric is the same. It does not need to know anything about the actual details since it has discovered some means of persuasion by which, before those who do not know, it appears to know more than those who know.

459c

Gorgias: Well, doesn't it make things much easier, Socrates, when, without having learned the other skills but just this one skill, you are no worse off than the other artificers?

459d

Socrates: We shall investigate presently whether or not the rhetorician is worse off than the others under such circumstances, if that is relevant to our discussion. But there is something we should consider first. When it comes to just and unjust, base and noble, good and bad, is the situation of the rhetorician the same as it was in the case of health, and the various concerns of the other skills? Without knowing what is good and bad, base and noble, just and unjust, could he bring about persuasion in relation to these so that, before those who do not know, he seems to know more than those who actually know, even though he doesn't know? Or is it necessary to know

these, and should the person who intends to learn rhetoric know these things before he arrives in front of you? And if not, will you, the teacher of rhetoric, decline to teach these subjects to the new arrival since it is not your job? And instead, although he does not know such matters, will you make him seem to know before the multitude, and seem to be good when he is not? Or will you be unable to teach him rhetoric at all if he does not know the truth about these matters in advance? What is the situation here, Gorgias? And by Zeus, as you said you would do earlier, please reveal rhetoric and state what precisely its power is.

460a

Gorgias: Well, I believe, Socrates, that if he happens not to know, then he will learn these matters from me too.

Socrates: Hold there! Yes, that is well expressed. If you are to make a rhetorician of someone, it is necessary for him either to know the just and the unjust beforehand, or learn these subsequently from you.

460b

Gorgias: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: What about this? Someone who has learned carpentry is a carpenter, is he not?

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: And is not someone who has learned music a musician?

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: And is someone who has learned medicine a physician? And does the same argument apply to the other subjects? Whoever learns any of them is, in each case, the sort of person that the knowledge makes him.

Gorgias: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Therefore, according to this argument, the person who has learned justice is just?

Gorgias: Entirely, of course.

Socrates: And presumably the just man performs just actions?

Gorgias: Yes.

460c

Socrates: Therefore, it is necessary that the rhetorician be just, and that the just man wishes to perform just actions.

Gorgias: So it appears anyway.

Socrates: So, the just man will never wish to act unjustly.

Gorgias: Necessarily.

Socrates: And according to the argument it is necessary that the rhetorician be just.

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: So, the rhetorician will never wish to act unjustly.

Gorgias: It appears not anyway.

460d

Socrates: Now, do you remember saying a little earlier that we should not blame the trainers or expel them from our cities if a trained boxer makes use of his boxing skill to act unjustly? And on the same basis, that if the rhetorician uses rhetoric unjustly, we should not blame the instructor or drive him out of our cities, but we should blame the one who acted unjustly and did not use rhetoric correctly? Is that what was said or is it not?

460e

Gorgias: That's what was said.

Socrates: But now it turns out that the same person, the rhetorician, would not ever act unjustly. Is this not so?

Gorgias: Apparently.

Socrates: And in our initial discussion it was said that rhetoric was concerned with speeches, not about number, odd and even, but about the just and the unjust. Is this so?

Gorgias: Yes.

Socrates: What is more, at the time you were saying all this, I understood that rhetoric would never be an unjust activity, since the speeches it makes are always about justice. But later on, when you said that the rhetorician could also use rhetoric unjustly, I was amazed at this, and being of the view that your statements were not concordant, I made those pronouncements, that if you were of the view, as I am, that there is an advantage in being refuted, it would be worthwhile to carry on a discussion, but if not, we should bid farewell to the matter. But of late, as we continue our investigation, you see for yourself that we are in agreement once more, that the rhetorician is unable to use rhetoric unjustly or to desire to act unjustly. So, Gorgias, by the dog,¹² we shall need considerable time together to investigate precisely how matters stand here.

461b

Polus: What's this, Socrates? Do you really believe what you are now saying about rhetoric? Or do you imagine that because Gorgias was ashamed not to agree with you about the man who studies rhetoric knowing the just and noble and good, and even if he were to frequent Gorgias without knowing these, he would teach him. Perhaps it was from this concession that a contradiction then showed up in his propositions, something that delights you as you draw people into questions of this sort. Yes, do you believe that anyone would totally deny that he himself knew about justice and would teach this to others? No, it is very crude of you to lead the discussions in such directions.

461c

Socrates: Please, most noble Polus, this surely is why we acquire companions and sons, so that when we ourselves get

older and stumble, you younger men are there to put our lives right once more, both in word and in deed. And now, if Gorgias and I have made some stumble in our discussions, here you are to put us right. It is your duty, and if it seems to you that anything that has been agreed has not been agreed fairly, then I am willing to retract whatever you wish, if you would just watch out for one thing for my sake.

461d

Polus: What are you referring to?

Socrates: That you restrain the lengthy manner of speaking that you tried to use earlier, Polus.

Polus: What's this? Shall I not be allowed to say just as much as I want to?

Socrates: Best of men, you would surely be in an outrageous predicament if, having arrived in Athens, where there is more freedom of speech than anywhere else in Greece, you were the only person there who did not attain it. But look at it the other way. If you speak at length and are not willing to answer what you are asked, would not my predicament be even more outrageous if I was not allowed to leave and stop listening to you? Rather, if anything in the discussion that has just taken place bothers you and you wish to put it right, then, as I said just now, retract whatever you wish, take your turn in questioning and being questioned, just like myself and Gorgias, and practise refuting and being refuted. Now, I presume you also claim to know the same things as Gorgias. Is this so?

461e

Polus: I do indeed.

Socrates: In that case, do you also frequently call upon people to ask you any question they want, on the basis that you are knowledgeable in answering?

462a

Polus: Yes, certainly.

462b

Socrates: So, you should now do whichever of these you prefer, ask or answer.

Polus: That's what I'll do then, and you should answer me, Socrates. Since Gorgias seems to you to be in perplexity in relation to rhetoric, what do you say that it is?

Socrates: Are you asking me what kind of skill I say that it is?

Polus: I am.

Socrates: Since I should speak the truth to you, Polus, it seems to me anyway that it is not a skill at all.

Polus: Then what do you think rhetoric is?

462c

Socrates: An activity which you claim to have made into a skill in your treatise, which I have recently read.

Polus: What activity do you mean?

Socrates: I mean a practice.

Polus: So, does rhetoric seem to you to be a practice?

Socrates: To me it does, unless you can suggest an alternative.

Polus: Practice of what?

Socrates: A practice of bringing about some gratification and pleasure.

Polus: Don't you think rhetoric is noble since it is able to gratify people?

462d

Socrates: What is this, Polus? Have you already found out from me what I assert that rhetoric is? Is that why you are asking the subsequent question about whether I think it is noble?

Polus: Well, didn't I find out that you say it is a practice?

Socrates: Well, since you have such respect for gratification, are you prepared to gratify me, just a little?

Polus: I am indeed.

Socrates: Ask me now what skill I think cookery is.

Polus: I am asking you then. What skill is cookery?

Socrates: It is not a skill, Polus.

Polus: I am saying so.

Socrates: It is a practice.

Polus: I am saying so.

462e

Socrates: Of bringing about gratification and pleasure, Polus.

Polus: So, is cookery the same thing as rhetoric?

Socrates: Not at all, but it is a part of the same pursuit.

Polus: What pursuit do you mean?

Socrates: It may sound somewhat crude if I speak the truth. Indeed, I am reluctant to speak on Gorgias' account in case he thinks I am mocking his own pursuit. Now, what I call rhetoric is part of an activity that is not the fairest of activities, but I do not know if this is the rhetoric that Gorgias engages in, for earlier on nothing clear emerged from our discussion as to what precisely this man believes.

463a

Gorgias: Say what it is, Socrates. Don't be ashamed on my account.

Socrates: Well then, it seems to me, Gorgias, to be a pursuit devoid of skill, and yet it belongs to an intuitive soul that is also courageous and naturally clever in dealing with humanity. And,

in summary, I call this flattery. Now, I do think that there are many other parts of this pursuit, but one of them is indeed cookery, which actually seems to be a skill but, according to my account, it is not a skill, but practice and habit. I also refer to rhetoric as part of this, as are beautification and sophistry – four parts associated with four activities. Now, if Polus wishes to enquire, he should enquire, although he has not yet enquired as to what sort of part of flattery I assert that rhetoric is. No, he has not noticed that I have not yet answered that question, so he proceeds to ask if I regard it as noble. But I shall not answer him as to whether I regard rhetoric as noble or base until I have first answered what it is. No, that would not be right, Polus. But if you really do wish to engage in enquiry ask me what sort of part of flattery I say that rhetoric is.

463d

Polus: That's my question, then. So tell me what sort of part it is.

Socrates: Now, will you understand my answer? Rhetoric, according to my account, is an image of part of politics.

Polus: What else? Are you saying that it is noble or base?

Socrates: Base, in my view anyway, for I refer to what is bad as base, since I must respond to you as if you have already understood what I mean.

Gorgias: By Zeus, Socrates, I don't understand what you mean either.

463e

Socrates: Gorgias, it is quite likely that I am not making my meaning clear, but Polus here is young and impetuous.

Gorgias: Just leave him be and tell me what you mean by saying that rhetoric is an image of part of politics.

Socrates: Then I shall try to state what rhetoric appears – to me anyway – to be. And if it happens not to be what I say it is, Polus here will refute me. I presume there is something you call body and something you call soul?

Gorgias: How could there not be?

464a

Socrates: In that case, do you also think that there is some good condition of each of these?

Gorgias: I do indeed.

Socrates: What about this? Can they seem to be in good condition when they are not? I am referring to a situation such as the following. Many people seem to have their bodies in good condition, and it is not easy for anyone to discern that they are not in good condition, but the physician and any physical trainer can do so.

Gorgias: What you say is true.

Socrates: I am referring to the sort of thing, present in body and in soul, which makes body and soul seem to be in good condition, when, in fact, they possess no more than that seeming.

Gorgias: There are such things.

464b

Socrates: Come on now, and if I can I will give you a clearer demonstration of what I mean. Since there are two activities, I am saying there are two skills. One is directed to the soul and I call it politics, but the single skill directed to the body I cannot name for you off-hand. Yet, I am saying that care of the body is one, though it has two parts – gymnastic and medicine. And in the field of politics, the legislative part corresponds to gymnastic, while justice is the counterpart of medicine. Now, each of these does indeed have something in

common, one with the other – medicine with gymnastic, and justice with law-making – inasmuch as they are associated with the same thing, and yet they are somewhat different from one another. So, there are these four, and they always aim for the best in caring for what belongs to the body, on the one hand, and what belongs to the soul, on the other. Now, flattery notices this. I do not mean that she knows, but she guesses. She divides herself into four, adopts the guise of each of the four, and pretends to be the one whose guise she adopts. Then, devoid of any understanding of what is best, she uses the pleasure of the moment to hunt instead for folly, and she practises deception so as to seem to be of the utmost value. So cookery, having adopted the guise of medicine, also pretends to know what foods are best for the body so that if the cook and the physician had to contest the matter before children, or before men who were just as silly as children, as to whether the physician or the cook had more expertise about wholesome or harmful foods, the physician would die of starvation. Now, this is what I call flattery, and I say that something of this sort is base because it guesses at pleasure regardless of what is best, *Polus*, and that is my reply to you. But I say that it is not a skill, but a practice, because it does not possess any rational account of the nature of what it applies to, or of what those things are applied to, so that it is unable to express the cause of each. And I do not call an activity devoid of an account a skill. Yet, if you wish to contest these assertions, I am prepared to defend the argument.

Now, cookery is the flattery that hides behind medicine, while in the very same way beautification hides behind gymnastic, and in this sense it is a bad influence, deceptive, ignoble and slavish. It practises deception through shaping, colouring, smoothing and dressing-up in such a way as to

make an alien beauty intrude, to the neglect of the native beauty brought about by means of gymnastic. Now, to avoid being long-winded, I wish to talk to you as the geometers do, for at this stage you are probably following me. What beautification is to gymnastic, so is cookery to medicine; and, more to the point, what beautification is to gymnastic so is sophistry to law-making; and what cookery is to medicine so is rhetoric to justice. Well, as I say, on this basis they are distinct by nature, yet insofar as they are closely related, sophists and rhetoricians become confounded into sameness,¹³ concerned also with the same issues, and they themselves do not know how to make use of themselves, nor does the rest of humanity know how to use them. And, indeed, if the soul did not rule over the body but the body ruled over itself, and cookery and medicine were not contemplated by means of soul and distinguished from one another, but the body itself were to decide using its own delectation as the measure, the sameness of Anaxagoras would take over, my dear Polus. Indeed, you are familiar with his sayings. Everything would be confounded into sameness, and medicine, health and cookery would be indistinguishable.

So, now you have heard what I say that rhetoric is: the counterpart in the soul of cookery, doing in the soul what cookery does in the body. And yet, I have surely done something unusual, because, whilst not allowing you to deliver lengthy speeches, I myself have delivered an extremely protracted one. However, I do deserve forgiveness, for when I spoke briefly you did not understand, nor were you able to make use of the answer I gave you; rather, you required further elaboration. And, indeed, if I am unable to make use of your answers when you respond to me, you should protract your speech too, but if I can use them, allow me to use them. That is only fair. And now, if you are able to

make any use of this answer, use it.

466a

Polus: What's your point then? Do you think that rhetoric is flattery?

Socrates: I said, in fact, that it is part of flattery. Can you not remember at your age, Polus? What will happen to you in later life?

Polus: And do the good rhetoricians seem to you to be held in low regard in the cities because they are flatterers?

466b

Socrates: Is this a question, or are you starting to deliver a speech?

Polus: I am just asking.

Socrates: In my view, anyway, they are not regarded at all.

Polus: How could they not be regarded? Don't they exercise enormous power in our cities?

Socrates: Not if you mean that the exercise of power is something good for the powerful person.

Polus: But of course I mean that.

Socrates: Then it seems to me that the rhetoricians exercise less power than anyone else in the city.

466c

Polus: But why? Aren't they just like tyrants? Don't they kill anyone they wish, confiscate property, and expel from the cities whoever seems to them to deserve it?

Socrates: By the dog, Polus, I am in two minds on each of the points you are making. Do you yourself mean this, and are you expressing your own opinion or are you asking me a question?

466d

Polus: Yes, I am asking you a question.

Socrates: So be it, my friend. In that case, are you asking me two questions at once?

Polus: In what way are there two?

Socrates: Did you not just say something of this sort: “Can’t the rhetoricians kill anyone they wish, just like tyrants, confiscate property, and expel from the cities whoever seems to them to deserve it?”

Polus: I did, indeed.

Socrates: Then, I am saying that there are two questions here, and I shall give you an answer in relation to both. Indeed, I assert, Polus, that both the rhetoricians and the tyrants exercise the least power in the cities, as I said a moment ago. For, in a sense, they do nothing they wish. Instead, they do whatever seems to them to be best.

466e

Polus: Isn’t that the exercise of enormous power?

Socrates: Not according to Polus anyway.

Polus: Am I denying this? No, I am asserting this.

Socrates: By the... No, you are not, since you assert that the exercise of enormous power is a good to the powerful person.

Polus: Yes, that’s what I assert.

Socrates: Well, do you think it is good if someone who does not possess intelligence does whatever seems to him to be the best? And do you refer to this as the exercise of enormous power?

Polus: I do not.

467a

Socrates: In that case, once you have refuted me, will you demonstrate that the rhetoricians possess intelligence, and rhetoric is a skill and not flattery? And if you leave me unrefuted, the rhetoricians, who do whatever seems best to

them in the cities, and the tyrants will have acquired nothing good thereby. But, according to you, the power is good. Yet you also agree that doing what seems best without intelligence is bad, do you not?

Polus: I do.

Socrates: So, how could rhetoricians exercise enormous power in the cities, or tyrants either, unless they really are doing what they wish, and Socrates is thus refuted by Polus?

467b

Polus: This man!

Socrates: I deny that they are doing what they wish. Now refute me!

Polus: Didn't you just agree that they do what seems best to them?

Socrates: And I still agree now.

Polus: In that case, don't they do what they wish?

Socrates: That I deny.

Polus: Are they doing what seems best to them?

Socrates: That's what I am saying.

Polus: What you are saying is shocking, Socrates, extremely so.

Socrates: Do not make accusations, precious Polus, if I may address you in your own manner. Rather, question me if you are able to and prove that I am speaking falsely. Otherwise you should respond to me.

467c

Polus: Then I'm willing to respond so that I actually understand what you are saying.

Socrates: Well, what do you think people wish for, the action they are performing at the time or that for the sake of which

they perform the action they are performing? Take, for instance, those who drink medicine at the behest of the physicians. Do you think they wish for the action they are performing – drinking the medicine and suffering its effects – or is it for something else, for the healthy condition, that for the sake of which they drink it?

467d

Polus: Obviously it is the healthy condition.

Socrates: And in the case of those who undertake sea voyages or engage in other money-making activities, it is not the activity that they wish for, the one they are performing at the time, for who wishes to be at sea, running risks and enduring hardship? No, I think they travel by sea for the sake of something else, to be wealthy, for they take to the sea for the sake of wealth.

Polus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: So, does not the same go for all other actions? If anyone does anything for the sake of something, he does not wish for the action he is performing, but for that for the sake of which he performs the action.

467e

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, among things that are, is not everything either good or bad, or in between these two, neither good nor bad?

Polus: This simply must be so, Socrates.

Socrates: Would you not say that wisdom, health and wealth and the like are good, while the opposites of these are bad?

Polus: I would indeed.

468a

Socrates: And do you say that the things that are neither good nor bad are those which sometimes partake of the good and

sometimes of the bad and sometimes of neither, like sitting, walking, running and sailing, or indeed stones and wood and anything else of that sort? Are you not referring to these? Or do you refer to some other things as neither good nor bad?

Polus: No, just these.

Socrates: Now, which is it? Whenever people perform actions, do they perform those in-between actions for the sake of whatever is good, or the good actions for the sake of the in-between?

468b

Polus: The in-between for the sake of the good, of course.

Socrates: So, whenever we walk, we walk in pursuit of the good, thinking it better to do so. And in the opposite case we stand, when we do stand, for the same reason, for the sake of the good. Is this not so?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: Therefore, too, if we kill someone, do we not kill them, or banish them or confiscate their property, thinking that it is better for us to do so rather than not do so?

Polus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: So, those who do all of these things do them for the sake of the good.

Polus: I agree.

Socrates: Have we agreed, then, that whenever we perform actions for the sake of something else, we do not wish for those activities, but for that for the sake of which we do them?

468c

Polus: Very much so.

Socrates: So, we do not wish to butcher people or expel them from our cities or confiscate their property just like that. But

when these actions are beneficial we wish to perform them, and when they are harmful we do not wish to do so. For we wish for whatever is good, as you say, but we do not wish for what is neither good nor bad, or what is bad, do we? Do you think what I am saying is true or not, Polus? Why do you not answer?

Polus: True.

468d

Socrates: Therefore, since we are agreed on all this, if anyone, either a tyrant or a rhetorician, kills someone or banishes them from the city or confiscates their possessions, thinking that it is better for himself and it happens to be worse, this man is obviously doing whatever seems best to him. Is this so?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, is he also doing what he wishes, if these actions happen to be bad for him? Why do you not answer?

Polus: Well, I don't think that he is doing what he wishes.

468e

Socrates: So, is there any sense in which such a person is exercising enormous power in that city, since, as you agreed, the exercise of enormous power is something good?

Polus: There is not.

Socrates: Then, I spoke the truth when I said that it is possible for a man who is doing what seems best to him in a city not to be exercising enormous power or doing what he wishes.

Polus: Yes, Socrates, as if you would not welcome the opportunity of doing whatever seems best to you in the city, given the choice, nor would you envy someone whom you saw killing whoever seemed to him to deserve it, or confiscating his property or putting people in chains.

469a

Socrates: Do you mean justly or unjustly?

Polus: Whatever he does, isn't it enviable in either case?

Socrates: Mind what you say, Polus.

Polus: Why so?

Socrates: Because the unenviable must not be envied, nor should the wretched. In fact, they should be pitied.

Polus: What's this? Do you think that the men I am referring to are in that situation?

Socrates: How could they not be?

469b

Polus: Well, do you think someone is wretched and pitiable when he has killed someone who seems to him to deserve it and the killing is just?

Socrates: I do not think so, but he is not enviable either.

Polus: Didn't you say just now that he is wretched?

Socrates: That was the person who did the killing unjustly, and he is pitiable as well. But the one who does it justly is unenviable.

Polus: Surely it is the person who has been unjustly killed who is pitiable and wretched.

Socrates: Less than the person who killed him, Polus, and less than someone who is justly killed.

Polus: How can that be, Socrates?

Socrates: On the basis that doing injustice happens to be the greatest of evils.

469c

Polus: Is it the greatest? Isn't it a greater evil to suffer injustice?

Socrates: Not in the least.

Polus: So, would you prefer to suffer injustice rather than do injustice?

Socrates: I myself would prefer neither. But if it were necessary either to do injustice or to suffer injustice, I would choose to suffer injustice rather than do injustice.

Polus: So, you would not welcome being a tyrant?

Socrates: Not if you mean what I mean by being a tyrant anyway.

Polus: Well, I mean what I said already, being able to do whatever seems best to you in the city – killing, banishing, and doing everything based upon your own opinion.

469d

Socrates: Bless you. Then think about what I am going to say. Suppose I were in a crowded market-place carrying a dagger under my arm, and I said to you, “Polus, I have just been granted a wonderful and tyrannical power. Yes, if it should seem to me that one of these men whom you see deserves to die right now, the man I think should die shall die. And if it should seem to me that one of them should have his head smashed, smashed it will be there and then. And if his cloak should be torn, torn it will be, so great is the power I shall exercise in this city.” Now, if you did not believe me and I were to show you the dagger, you would probably look at it and say, “Socrates, anyone at all could exercise great power in this manner since, based on this approach, you could also burn down any house you thought you should, and the dockyards of Athens, triremes included, and all the ships, public as well as private.” But this is not really the exercise of great power, doing what seems best to you. Or do you think it is?

469e

Polus: Of course not, not when it's done in this way anyway.

470a

Socrates: Now, can you say why you deprecate power of this sort?

Polus: I can.

Socrates: Why so? Tell me.

Polus: Because it is necessary for the person who behaves in this way to undergo punishment.

Socrates: And is it not bad to undergo punishment?

Polus: Very much so.

Socrates: In that case, my wonderful friend, once again you are of the view that, provided acting as seems best to you corresponds to acting beneficially, it is good, and this seemingly is the possession of great power. But, if not, it is bad and is insignificant power. But let us also consider this. Do we not agree that it is sometimes good to do the deeds we mentioned, to kill and to banish people and confiscate their property, and sometimes it is not?

470b

Polus: Very much so.

Socrates: Then this point, it seems, is agreed by you and by me.

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: So, when do you say it is better to do these deeds? Tell me what distinction you make.

Polus: You should answer that question, Socrates.

470c

Socrates: Well, Polus, if it is more pleasant for you to hear this from me, I say that whenever anyone does these deeds justly, it is better. Whenever anyone does them unjustly, it is worse.

Polus: Oh! You are so hard to refute, Socrates! Couldn't a mere child refute you and show you are not speaking the truth?

Socrates: Then I shall be very grateful to the child, and equally so to you if you happen to refute me and rid me of folly. So do not tire of doing good deeds for a man who is your friend. Refute me.

470d

Polus: Well then, Socrates, there is no need to refer to ancient deeds in order to refute you. Indeed, recent and not so recent events are enough to refute you and show that many people who act unjustly are happy.

Socrates: What sort of events?

Polus: You see, don't you, that this Archelaus fellow, the son of Perdiccas, is ruling Macedonia?

Socrates: Not really, but I have heard this.

Polus: Well, do you think he is happy or is he wretched?

Socrates: I do not know, Polus, for I have not yet been in the man's company.

470e

Polus: What's this? You would know if you were in his company, but otherwise you do not simply recognise that he is happy?

Socrates: By Zeus, of course I do not.

Polus: Then, Socrates, it is obvious that you will say that you do not recognise that even the Great King is happy.¹⁴

Socrates: And I shall be speaking the truth, for I do not know how he stands with regard to justice and education.

Polus: Come now, is all happiness contained in this?

Socrates: That is what I say anyway, Polus. For I assert that the noble and good men and women are happy, while the unjust and degenerate are wretched.

471a

Polus: So by your account, this Archelaus fellow is wretched?

Socrates: Yes, my friend, if he is unjust.

Polus: But how could he not be unjust? None of the authority he now exercises belonged to him, as he was born of a woman who was a slave of Alcetas, the brother of Perdiccas, so, by right, he was a slave of Alcetas. And if he had wished to enact what is just, he would have acted as a slave to Alcetas and would have been happy, according to your account. But now, wonder of wonders, he has become wretched, since he has perpetrated enormous injustices. Anyway, he first sent for this man, his own master and uncle, on the pretext of restoring the authority that Perdiccas had taken from him. Once he had entertained Alcetas, he got him drunk along with his son Alexander – Archelaus' own cousin of almost the same age – threw them into a wagon, led them away by night, slit their throats, and they were never seen again. Having perpetrated these injustices, he failed to notice that he had become utterly wretched, and he did not mend his ways. No, a little later he showed no wish to become happy by rearing his own seven-year-old brother, the legitimate son of Perdiccas, in a just manner and bestowing the throne upon him, to whom it devolved by right. Instead, he threw him into a well and drowned him, and told the boy's mother, Cleopatra, that he had fallen in and died whilst running after a goose. And of course, since he has behaved more unjustly than anyone in Macedonia, he is the most wretched of all the Macedonians, and not the happiest. And perhaps there is some Athenian, who, following your example, would prefer to be any other Macedonian rather than Archelaus.

471d

Socrates: Indeed, Polus, at the beginning of these discussions I praised you because I thought you had been well educated in rhetoric but had neglected dialectic. And now, is this the argument by which a child could refute me? And do you think I

have been refuted by you, by means of this argument, I who assert that those who act unjustly are not happy? Where is the refutation, good man? On the contrary, I do not agree with anything you are saying.

Polus: You actually don't want to, yet you are thinking what I am saying.

471e

Socrates: Bless you! You are trying to refute me in a rhetorical manner, just like those who believe they are engaging in refutation in courts of law. Yes, indeed, in those places, one party seems to refute another once they bring forward many well-regarded witnesses in support of the speeches they deliver, while the opposing speaker furnishes only one or none. But this refutation is of no value with regard to truth. For on occasion, anyone may be subject to false testimony from numerous witnesses who are held in some regard. And now, with few exceptions, all Athenians and strangers alike will say the same things you say, should you wish to bring witnesses against me to say I am not speaking the truth. They will testify for you if you wish: Nicias, the son of Niceratus, and his brothers too, whose tripods stand in a row in the Sanctuary of Dionysus; Aristocrates, the son of Skellias, whose beautiful statue stands in the Pythian precinct, if you wish; the entire household of Pericles too, or any other family you wish to select from among this company.¹⁵ But I, being one, do not agree with you for you do not compel me. Instead, you furnish many false witnesses against me in your efforts to divorce me from my property, the truth. But if I do not produce you yourself as one witness who agrees with what I am saying, then I think I have achieved nothing worth mentioning in relation to the subjects of our discussion. And neither have you, unless I, one solitary person, bear witness for you, and you bid all those

others farewell.

Now, this is the particular manner of refutation which you and many others accept. Yet there is another, which I, for my part, believe in.

So, let us place them side by side and find out if there is any difference between them. What is more, the issues over which we are disputing are not completely trivial. No, to have knowledge of these matters is almost the fairest acquisition of all, and to lack this knowledge is utterly base, for at the heart of all this is knowing or being ignorant, of who is happy and who is not. First, there is the immediate issue under discussion at the moment. You think it is possible for a man to be blessed although he is unjust and acting unjustly, since you think that Archelaus is unjust and yet happy. May we regard this as your viewpoint?

472d

Polus: Very much so.

Socrates: But I say this is impossible. That is one issue we are disputing. So be it. He will be happy although he is acting unjustly, but what if he meets with justice and punishment?

Polus: He's least happy, since he would be utterly wretched under those circumstances.

472e

Socrates: But if the person acting unjustly does not meet with justice, then, according to your account, he will be happy.

Polus: I agree.

Socrates: But in my view, Polus, the one who is unjust and acting unjustly is utterly wretched anyway. However, he is more wretched if he does not pay a penalty and does not receive punishment as a wrongdoer. But he is less wretched if he does

pay a penalty and meets with justice at the hands of gods and men.

473a

Polus: You are trying to express some strange notions, Socrates.

Socrates: And I shall also try anyway to make you, my colleague, say the same things to me, for I regard you as a friend. Well then, these are the issues on which we now differ, and you should consider these. Did I not say a while ago that doing injustice is worse than suffering it?

Polus: You certainly did.

Socrates: But you said suffering injustice is worse.

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: And I said that those who act unjustly are wretched, and I was refuted by you.

Polus: Yes, by Zeus.

473b

Socrates: So you think, Polus.

Polus: What I think is true.

Socrates: Perhaps, and you say anyway that those who act unjustly are happy, provided they do not pay a penalty.

Polus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And I say these people are utterly wretched, but those who pay a penalty are less so. Would you also like to refute this?

Polus: Oh, Socrates, this is even more difficult to refute than the other.

Socrates: Not at all, Polus, it is impossible! For the truth is never refuted.

473c

Polus: What are you saying? If a man is caught engaging in unjust action, striving to become a tyrant, and is put on the rack, castrated, has his eyes burned out, and is subjected to a host of other outrageous abuses, sees his own children and wife abused too, and is finally impaled and tarred, will this fellow be happier than if he had evaded this, set himself up as a tyrant, and spent his life ruling the city, doing as he wished, envied and accounted happy by citizens and strangers alike? Are you saying that all this is impossible to refute?

473d

Socrates: Now, you are telling horror stories, noble Polus, and a moment ago you were calling witnesses, but you are not engaging in refutation. But in any case, remind me of one detail. Did you say he was striving unjustly to become a tyrant?

Polus: I did.

473e

Socrates: Then neither of them will ever be happier, neither the one who manages to become a tyrant by unjust means nor the one who pays a penalty, for of two wretches, neither would be happier. However, the one who evades justice and becomes a tyrant is more wretched. What is this, Polus? Are you laughing? Is this yet another form of refutation – to laugh at someone when they say something, but not refute them?

Polus: Do you think you haven't been refuted, Socrates, when you are saying things the like of which no man at all would assert? Ask anyone here!

Socrates: Oh, Polus, I am not one of your politicians. And last year I was allotted membership of the Council,¹⁶ but when my tribe¹⁷ had the Presidency¹⁸ and I had to cast my vote, I became a figure of fun as I was unable to cast it. So, do not call upon me now to take the votes of the people here. Rather, if you do not have a better refutation than these, then, as I said a moment

ago, let me have my turn and try out the kind of refutation that I deem necessary. For I know how to furnish just one witness of what I am saying, the person with whom my conversation takes place, but I bid the multitudes farewell. And I know how to take the vote from one, and I do not even engage in discussions with multitudes. Now, let us see if you are prepared, in turn, to provide an opportunity for refutation by answering whatever you are asked. Indeed, I am of the view that both you and I, and all these other men, hold that doing injustice is worse than suffering injustice, and not paying a penalty is worse than paying it.

474b

Polus: I, for one, don't think that I or any other man at all holds this view. So, would you accept the infliction of injustice in preference to acting unjustly?

Socrates: Yes. You would too, and so would everyone else.

Polus: Far from it. No. I wouldn't, you wouldn't, and neither would anyone else.

Socrates: In that case, will you respond?

Polus: Yes, certainly. In fact, I am eager to know what precisely you are going to say.

Socrates: Then, Polus, so that you may know, tell me, as if I were questioning you from the beginning, which seems worse to you, doing injustice or suffering injustice?

474c

Polus: Suffering injustice, in my view anyway.

Socrates: But what about this? Which is the more base, doing injustice or suffering injustice? Answer.

Polus: Doing injustice.

Socrates: In that case, it is also worse if, in fact, it is more base.

Polus: Not in the least.

Socrates: I understand. It seems you do not think that noble and good, bad and base are the same.

Polus: Of course not.

474d

Socrates: What about the following? In the case of anything noble, such as bodies, colours, shapes, sounds and activities, do you refer to each of them as noble without looking to something else? Firstly, for instance, do you not say that noble bodies are noble either on the basis of their use, what each is useful for, or on the basis of some pleasure, if the beholding engenders delight in the beholders? Have you anything besides this to say about the nobility of the body?

Polus: I have not.

475a

Socrates: Does not the same apply to all the others, and do you not refer to shapes and colours as noble because of some pleasure or benefit or both?

Polus: I do indeed.

Socrates: Do you not also refer similarly to sounds and all elements associated with music?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: And, indeed, in the case of the laws or any activities, these presumably are not noble because of anything apart from being beneficial or pleasant or both.

Polus: I don't think so anyway.

Socrates: Does not the same apply to the nobility of whatever we learn?

Polus: Yes, certainly. And you are defining this nicely now, Socrates, defining the noble in terms of pleasure and goodness.

Socrates: Do we not define the base in terms of the opposite, in terms of pain and by badness?

Polus: Necessarily.

Socrates: So, whenever there are two noble things and one is more noble than the other, it is more noble by exceeding in one or both of these factors, in pleasure or in benefit or in both.

Polus: Yes, certainly.

475b

Socrates: But when the two are base, and one is more base, it will be more base by exceeding either in pain or in badness. Must not this be so?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: Come then! What was said just now about doing injustice and suffering injustice? Did you not say that suffering injustice is more bad, and doing injustice is more base?

Polus: I said so.

Socrates: Therefore, if, in fact, doing injustice is more base than suffering injustice, it is either more painful and would be more base by exceeding it in pain or in badness, or in both. Is this not also necessarily so?

Polus: How could it not be so?

475c

Socrates: Then let us consider this first. Does the perpetration of injustice exceed the suffering of injustice in pain, and are those who act unjustly more pained than those who suffer injustice?

Polus: Not at all, Socrates. It is not this.

Socrates: So, it does not exceed it in pain anyway.

Polus: Certainly not.

Socrates: Therefore, if it does not exceed it in pain, it would not exceed it in both.

Polus: Apparently not.

Socrates: In that case only the other factor remains.

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: The badness.

Polus: So it seems.

Socrates: Therefore, doing injustice would be worse than suffering injustice because it exceeds it in badness.

Polus: Yes, that is obvious.

475d

Socrates: Do not most men agree, and did you not agree with me a while ago, that doing injustice is more base than suffering injustice?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: But now it turns out to be more bad.

Polus: So it seems.

Socrates: Well, would you accept the more base and bad in preference to what is less so? Do not be reluctant to answer, Polus, for no harm will come to you. Just surrender nobly to the argument as though it were a physician. Answer, and either affirm or deny whatever I ask you.

475e

Polus: No, I would not accept that, Socrates.

Socrates: Would any other man?

Polus: I do not think so, not on the basis of this argument anyway.

Socrates: So, I was speaking the truth. Neither I, nor you, nor any other man, would accept the perpetration of injustice rather than suffer injustice, for it happens to be more bad.

Polus: So it appears.

Socrates: Now, you see, Polus, that when one mode of refutation is set alongside the other, there is no resemblance between them. Although everyone else agrees with you except me, you are sufficient for me, one solitary person who agrees with me and testifies for me, and I am taking the vote from you alone and bidding the others farewell. And let that be our conclusion on this matter. Let us go on now and consider the second issue we were disputing about: whether, as you believe, the greatest evil for someone acting unjustly is to pay a penalty or, as I believe, the greater evil is not to pay a penalty. Let us look at it this way. Do you refer to paying a penalty and being justly disciplined for acting unjustly as the same thing?

476a

Polus: I do.

Socrates: Now, can you deny that everything that is just is noble, insofar as it is just? Think carefully before you answer.

Polus: I don't think I can deny this, Socrates.

Socrates: Then consider this too. If someone does something, must there also be something that suffers at the hands of that doer?

Polus: I think so.

Socrates: And does it experience what the doer enacts, and in the manner that the doer enacts it? I mean, for instance, that if someone is striking, something must be struck.

476b

Polus: It must.

Socrates: And if the striker strikes forcibly or quickly, is whatever is struck, struck in like manner?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: So, is the experience of whatever is struck akin to what the striker does?

Polus: Entirely so.

Socrates: Also, in the case in which someone burns, is it necessary that something be burned?

Polus: How could it be otherwise?

Socrates: And if he burns intensely or painfully, is whatever is burned, burned in the manner in which the burner burns?

Polus: Entirely so.

476c

Socrates: And in the case in which someone cuts, does the same argument apply?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: And if the cut is large or deep or painful, is whatever is cut, cut with the sort of cut that the cutter inflicts?

Polus: Apparently.

Socrates: Now, see if you agree with the concise statement I made earlier: in all circumstances, the sort of thing the doer does is the sort of thing the sufferer suffers.

Polus: Yes, I agree.

476d

Socrates: Well, based upon what we have agreed, is paying a penalty something that is suffered or something that is done?

Polus: It must be something that is suffered, Socrates.

Socrates: Therefore, it is being done by someone.

Polus: How could it not be? By the one who disciplines him.

476e

Socrates: And does he who disciplines rightly discipline justly?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: Is he performing just actions or is he not?

Polus: The actions are just.

Socrates: Therefore, is it the case that the one who is disciplined and pays a penalty suffers just actions?

Polus: Apparently.

Socrates: And it is agreed, I presume, that just actions are noble.

Polus: Entirely so.

Socrates: So, one of these people performs what is noble, and the other, the one who is disciplined, experiences this.

Polus: Yes.

477a

Socrates: Therefore, since they are noble, are they good? For noble actions are either pleasant or beneficial.

Polus: Necessarily.

Socrates: So, the person who pays a penalty experiences what is good?

Polus: So it seems.

Socrates: So, he is benefited?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: Is the benefit what I presume it to be? That his soul becomes better, if, in fact, he is justly disciplined.

Polus: Quite likely.

Socrates: So, is a person who pays a penalty released from badness of soul?

Polus: Yes.

477b

Socrates: In that case, is he released from the very worst badness? Think about this. When it comes to the state of a man's property, can you envisage any badness besides poverty?

Polus: No, only poverty.

Socrates: What about the condition of the body? Would you say that the badness is illness, disease, uncomeliness and the like?

Polus: I would.

Socrates: Do you not think that there is also some vice in the soul?

Polus: How could there not be?

Socrates: Do you not refer to this as injustice, ignorance, cowardice, and the like?

Polus: Yes, certainly.

477c

Socrates: Since there are wealth, body and soul, these three, you have mentioned three vices, poverty, disease and injustice.

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: Which of these vices is the most base? Is it not injustice, in short, the vice of the soul?

Polus: Very much so.

Socrates: If it is indeed the most base, is it also the worst?

Polus: What do you mean, Socrates?

Socrates: This. On the basis of what was agreed earlier, the base is always base either because it produces the greatest pain or

harm, or both.

Polus: Certainly.

477d

Socrates: And did we just agree that what is most base is injustice and all vice of the soul?

Polus: Yes, we agreed.

Socrates: Therefore, it is either the most distressing, and is the most base of these, because it exceeds in distress or in harm, or in both.

477e

Polus: Necessarily.

Socrates: Now, are injustice and indiscipline, cowardice and ignorance, more painful than being poor or being ill?

Polus: I don't think so, not from these arguments anyway.

Socrates: Now, since by your account at least, the vice of the soul does not exceed the others in pain, it is the most base of them all because it exceeds them extraordinarily in some great harm and astounding badness.

Polus: Apparently.

Socrates: However, I presume that whatever exceeds to the greatest extent in harm would be the greatest badness that there is.

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: In that case, is injustice, indiscipline and the general vice of the soul the greatest badness that there is?

Polus: Apparently.

478a

Socrates: Which skill frees one from poverty? Is it not the skill of money-making?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: What frees us from disease? Is it not medical skill?

Polus: Necessarily.

Socrates: And what frees us from vice and injustice? In case you have no ready answer, consider this. Where and to whom do we bring people whose bodies are ill?

Polus: To the physicians, Socrates.

Socrates: Where do we bring those who act unjustly or without discipline?

Polus: To the judges. Is that what you mean?

Socrates: So, that they may pay a penalty?

Polus: I agree.

Socrates: Now, do not the people who discipline them aright do so by recourse to some justice?

Polus: Obviously.

478b

Socrates: So, wealth-generation frees us from poverty, medical skill from disease, and justice from indiscipline and injustice.

Polus: Apparently.

Socrates: Then which of these is the noblest?

Polus: Of what?

Socrates: Of money-making, medical skill and justice.

Polus: Justice excels by far, Socrates.

Socrates: Furthermore, if, in fact, it is noblest, does it not produce the greatest pleasure or benefit or both?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, is medical treatment pleasant, and are those who undergo medical treatment pleased?

Polus: I do not think so.

Socrates: But it is beneficial anyway. Is this so?

Polus: Yes.

478c

Socrates: For it brings release from enormous badness, and so it is advantageous to endure the distress and become healthy.

Polus: How could it not be?

Socrates: Now, on this basis, with regard to the body, would the happiest man be the one who has undergone medical treatment, or the one who was not even ill in the first place?

Polus: Obviously the one who was not even ill.

Socrates: Then it seems that happiness is not the release from badness, but not acquiring it in the first place.

Polus: This is so.

478d

Socrates: What about this? If there are two people possessed of badness, either in body or in soul, which of the two is more wretched, the one who undergoes treatment and is released from the badness, or the one who does not undergo treatment and still has it?

Polus: The one who is not treated. So it appears to me.

Socrates: Was paying a penalty not a release from the greatest badness, namely vice?

Polus: It was.

Socrates: For justice, I suppose, makes one sound-minded and more just, and is a cure for evil.

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: So, the happiest person is the one who is possessed of no badness in soul, since this has turned out to be the worst badness of all.

478e

Polus: Yes, of course.

Socrates: Second happiest is, presumably, the person who is released from badness.

Polus: So it seems.

Socrates: And this is the fellow who is chastised, rebuked, and has paid a penalty.

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: So, the fellow who retains his badness and is not released from it lives the worst life.

Polus: Apparently.

Socrates: And is this not, in fact, the fellow who perpetrates the greatest injustices, and, despite using unjust means, arranges neither to be chastened nor disciplined nor to pay a penalty, just as you say Archelaus and other tyrants, rhetoricians and men of power contrive?

479a

Polus: So it seems.

Socrates: Indeed, best of men, in a sense these fellows have almost arranged to be in the same predicament as someone afflicted with serious illnesses who contrives not to pay a penalty to the physicians for the aberrations of the body, or to undergo treatment, fearing the burning and the cutting, just like a child, because it is painful. Or does it not seem like that to you too?

479b

Polus: It does.

Socrates: It seems they are somehow unaware of what health and excellence of body are like. For based upon what we have just concluded, these men who are evading justice, Polus, are also in danger of doing something similar: of clearly discerning the pain thereof but having a blind spot towards its benefit, and of being unaware of how much more wretched it is to live with a soul that is not healthy, a soul that is unsound, unjust and impious. Hence, they do anything so as neither to pay a penalty nor be released from this great badness, providing themselves with possessions and friends and the ability to speak as persuasively as possible. But if what we have agreed is true, Polus, can you see the consequences of the argument? Would you like me to sum them up?

479c

Polus: Unless you have something else to suggest.

479d

Socrates: Well, does it follow that injustice, and acting unjustly, is the greatest badness?

Polus: So it appears anyway.

Socrates: And did the release from this badness turn out to be the payment of a penalty?

Polus: It was probable.

Socrates: And is the non-payment a continuation of the badness?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: So, the second greatest badness is the perpetration of injustice, but the foremost and greatest badness of all is, by nature, doing injustice without paying a penalty.

479e

Polus: So it seems.

Socrates: Now, is this not, my friend, what we disagreed about: you, for your part, regarding Archelaus as happy, though he perpetrated enormous injustices without paying a penalty; and I, for my part, holding the opposite view, that if either Archelaus or any other person does not pay a penalty when he acts unjustly, he is inevitably wretched, more so than any other person, and that the perpetrator of injustice is always more wretched than the sufferer, and the one who pays no penalty is more wretched than he who pays one? Are these not the assertions I made?

Polus: Yes.

Socrates: Has it not been shown that what was asserted is true?

Polus: Apparently.

480a

Socrates: So be it. Now, if this is all true, Polus, what is the great advantage of rhetoric? In fact, on the basis of what is now agreed, a man should be particularly vigilant of himself in case he might act unjustly and get his fill of badness. Is this so?

Polus: Entirely so.

Socrates: But if either he or someone else for whom he cares acts unjustly, he will go willingly to wherever he may pay a penalty as quickly as possible, going to a judge just as he would to a physician, hastening lest the disease of injustice be protracted and make the soul fester and become incurable. Or how should we express this, Polus, if what we previously agreed still stands? Must not these assertions, expressed in this way but not otherwise, be in agreement with the earlier ones?

480b

Polus: Well then, Socrates, what should we say?

Socrates: So, rhetoric is not useful to us at all, Polus, in the defence of our own injustice, or that of our parents or

companions or children or fatherland, except if it is deployed for the opposite purpose – to prosecute oneself in particular, as one must, and, indeed, any other kinfolk or loved ones when they happen to act unjustly, not in order to conceal this, but to bring the unjust action to light in order that a penalty is paid and health is restored; to compel both himself and the others to show no cowardice, but to submit with closed eyes, worthily and courageously, as if he were being cut or burned by a physician; intent upon the good and the noble, taking no account of the pain; submitting to flogging, if his unjust deeds merit flogging; to imprisonment, if they merit imprisonment; paying the fine, if a fine is imposed; going into exile, if exile is deserved; and submitting to death, if execution is deserved; he himself being the chief accuser of himself, and of his other kinfolk, and making use of rhetoric for this purpose, so that with their unjust deeds fully exposed, they may be released from the greatest of evils, injustice. Should we formulate it like this, or should we not, Polus?

480e

Polus: It seems absurd to me, Socrates. However, to you it probably seems to be in line with what we said before.

Socrates: Then we must either dispense with the former statements as well, or these latter ones necessarily follow.

Polus: Yes, that's how matters stand.

Socrates: What is more, turning to the opposite case, if it proves necessary to act badly towards someone, be he an enemy or anyone else, then as long as you yourself are not being treated unjustly by that enemy – you do need to be careful about this – and the enemy treats someone else unjustly, one must contrive by every means, in word and in deed, that he pay no penalty and is not brought before a judge. But if he is brought, one must arrange that the enemy is acquitted and does not pay a penalty; and if he has stolen a lot of gold, that he does

not repay this but holds on to it and spends it unjustly and godlessly on himself and his own people; and if he is deserving of death for his unjust actions, arrange that he does not suffer death – yea, that this never happens – so that he becomes immortal as an evildoer, and if not, that he lives for as long as possible in such a plight. It seems to me, Polus, that rhetoric is useful for such purposes, seeing that its usefulness to those with no intention of acting unjustly is insignificant, if indeed it has any use at all, since in the previous discussion it appeared not to be useful at all.

481b

Callicles: Tell me, Chaerephon, is Socrates serious about all this or is he playing games?

Chaerephon: He seems to me, Callicles, to be exceedingly serious. However, there is nothing like asking the man himself.

481c

Callicles: By the gods, I am eager to ask. Tell me, Socrates, should we presume that you are now being serious or joking? For if you are serious, and these pronouncements you are making happen to be true, won't the life of every human being be turned upside-down? And won't we all, so it seems, be doing the complete opposite of what we should?

Socrates: Callicles, if people did not have some experience that was the same, some sharing one experience, others sharing another, but instead one of us underwent a unique experience different from everyone else, it would not be easy for him to describe his own experience to another. And I speak from a recognition that you and I happen to have gone through the same experience. We are two lovers, each with two loves. My two are Alcibiades, the son of Clinias,¹⁹ and philosophy. Yours are the Athenian demos and Demos, the son of Pyrilampes.²⁰ Clever and all as you are, I notice that you constantly change your stance back and forth because

you are unable to contradict what your favourite asserts, and what he declares to be the case. In the Assembly, when you are saying something and the Athenian populace deny that this is the case, you change your stance and propose whatever they wish. And also with this fair youth, the son of Pyrilampes, you are affected in a similar fashion, for you are unable to oppose the formulations and assertions of your favourite. And so, if anyone were ever surprised at what you say when you speak under those influences, because the assertions are so absurd, if you wanted to speak the truth you would probably tell him that unless someone stops your favourite from making those pronouncements, you will never stop uttering them either. Therefore, you should realise that it is also necessary to hear more statements of this sort from me, and you should not be surprised that I make them. Rather, you must stop philosophy, my favourite, from saying what she says.

For she is constantly stating what you are now hearing from me, my dear friend, and she is much less impulsive with me than my other favourite, for the words of this son of Clinias change from one moment to the next, while the words of philosophy are always the same. She is saying what now surprises you, although you were also present yourself as it was spoken. So, as I just said, you should either refute her by proving that doing injustice and acting unjustly without paying a penalty is not the most extreme badness that there is, or else, if you leave this statement unrefuted, by the dog, the god of Egypt,²¹ Callicles, Callicles will not be in agreement with you. Instead he will be in discord throughout his entire life. And yet, best of men, I, for my part, think it better that my lyre be out of tune and discordant, so too the chorus that I provide, and that most of humanity disagree with me and speak against me, rather than that I, being one, should be

discordant with and speak against myself.

482c

Callicles: Socrates, it seems to me that you are out of control in your arguments, like a true mob orator. Yes, you are making these appeals to the mob, now that Polus has met the very same fate that he accused Gorgias of meeting at your hands. Indeed, he pointed out, I believe that when you asked Gorgias whether Gorgias himself would teach justice to someone who came to him, wishing to learn rhetoric but without any knowledge of justice, the man was ashamed and said he would teach him only on account of human convention, because people would be indignant if he said otherwise. Of course, due to this concession, he himself was forced to speak against himself, the very thing you delight in. And he ridiculed you at the time – rightly so in my view – but now he himself, in turn, has suffered the same fate. And I am not much pleased with Polus on this particular issue, because he conceded to you that doing injustice is more base than suffering injustice. For out of this concession, he, for his part, got tangled up in the discussion at your hands and was reduced to silence, ashamed to say what he was thinking. Yes, Socrates, whilst claiming to be pursuing the truth, you are really diverting us into banalities and populisms, propositions that are not sound by nature, but only by convention. Yet, in general, these two, nature and convention, are opposed to one another. Therefore, if anyone is ashamed and does not dare to say what he thinks, he is compelled to utter contradictions. And of course, having recognised this piece of wisdom, you wreak havoc in the discussions, asking surreptitiously about the natural whenever someone mentions the conventional, and about the conventional when they refer to the natural. It happened just now in the references to doing injustice and suffering injustice. When Polus referred to what is base according to convention, you

pursued the argument according to nature. For by nature, everything that is more base, such as suffering injustice, is also more bad, whereas by convention, doing injustice is more base. Indeed, this predicament of suffering injustice does not belong to a man, but to some slave, for whom it is better to die than to live, someone who, on suffering injustice or being mistreated, is unable to defend himself or anyone else he cares for. But in my view, those who set down the laws are the weak people, the multitude. They institute the laws with a view to themselves and their own advantage, and they praise what they praise and censure what they censure. To intimidate the stronger people who have the power to get more than their share, and to ensure they don't get more than the multitude, they say that getting more than your share is base and unjust, and that seeking to have more than others constitutes unjust activity. For I believe that they themselves, being lesser men, would be delighted with an equal share. Of course, that's why they say that this 'seeking to have more than the multitude' is, by law, unjust and base, and they refer to it as unjust action. And yet I believe that nature itself testifies to this: that it is just for the superior men to have more than the inferior men, and for the more powerful to exceed the less powerful. And it is evident in many cases that this is so, both among animals in general, and in the cities and dynasties of men. What is just is decided in this way: the stronger rule over the weaker and have more than them.

To what conception of justice did Xerxes²² have recourse when he waged war against Greece, or his father against the Scythians? And we could describe countless other instances of this sort. Yet I believe these people are acting in accord with the nature of the just. Yes, by Zeus, in accord with the law of nature anyway, though probably not in accord with the

one we institute, moulding the superior and stronger men among us. Capturing them when they are young, as though they were lions, we reduce them to slaves with enchantments and beguilements, declaring that equality is what is needed, and that's what's noble and just. And yet, if a man whose nature is up to the task were to arise, having shrugged off all this, broken it asunder and fled, trampled upon our traditions, aphorisms, verses, and all laws that are opposed to nature, that slave would prove to be our master, and the justice of nature would blaze forth. And it seems to me that Pindar makes the point I am making in the ode in which he says that

*Law the lord of all,
of mortals and immortals both...*

and then he says, it

*conducts extreme violence
with a high hand and renders it just.
My proof lies in the deeds of Heracles,
When, without payment...²³*

It says something of that sort, for I don't know the ode. But it does say that he drove off the cattle of Geryon²⁴ without payment and without permission, because by nature that's what is just. Both the oxen and all the other possessions of the lesser and the weaker belong to the superior and the stronger.

Now, that is the truth of the matter, and you will recognise this once you have bidden farewell to philosophy and moved on to greater things. Yes, philosophy is indeed a delight if it is taken up in due measure at the right age, but if a man

continues its practice for longer than necessary, it can ruin people. For even if he has great natural endowments, but engages in philosophy beyond the right age, a man must perforce remain inexperienced in all matters where experience is needed, by anyone who intends to be a noble, good man who is well thought of. In fact, he is rendered inexperienced in the laws governing the city and the language one must use to engage in the business dealings of men, be they public or private, in the pleasures and desires of humanity, and, in short, he becomes completely inexperienced in the ways of the world. So, once they take to any private or political business they become laughing stocks, just as the men of politics would, I presume, become laughable too if they in turn were to take up this activity of yours and its arguments. And this confirms the statement of Euripides that 'each person shines in this and is eager for this',

*Assigning the greater part of the day to this
Where he himself excels...*²⁵

But he shuns and reviles the activity in which he is inferior, and he praises the other one out of good will towards himself, believing that he himself is praising himself by doing so, but in my view it is best to have a share of both. Insofar as philosophy is educational, it is good to partake thereof, and it is no disgrace for a young man to engage in philosophy. However, if he still engages in philosophy as an older man, he becomes a comical character, Socrates, and I myself have exactly the same feeling towards the philosophers as I do towards people who mumble or behave childishly. For when I see a little child mumbling and being immature, it is still appropriate for him to converse in this manner, so I am pleased and it seems delightful to me, free-spirited and suited

to the age of the child. However, when I hear a young child expressing himself articulately, this seems distasteful to me. It offends my ears, and I regard it as more appropriate for a slave. And whenever anyone hears a man mumbling or sees him behaving immaturely, this appears comical and unmanly and deserving of a beating. Now, I myself have the very same feeling towards the philosophers, for I am delighted when I see philosophy in a young adolescent. It seems appropriate to me, and I regard this man as a free-spirited person, and the one who does not engage in philosophy as devoid of freedom, one who will never prove himself worthy of any fair and noble dealings. And yet, when I see an older man still engaging in philosophy and not giving it up, at that stage, Socrates, the man seems to me to be in need of a beating. For as I said just now, even if this man has many natural endowments, he is prone to become unmanly, avoiding the centres and meeting places of the city – in which, as the poet says,²⁶ men become illustrious – slinking away to live the rest of his life whispering with three or four adolescents in a corner, never expressing anything unbridled and visionary to meet the need of the moment.

Now, Socrates, I do have a somewhat friendly disposition towards you, so having been reminded of Zethus, I am now inclined to have the same feeling as he had towards Amphion in Euripides' play.²⁷ In fact, it occurs to me to say the same sort of things to you as he said to his brother: "Socrates, you care not for what you should, and although your soul has been granted a noble nature, you are pre-eminent in the guise of some youthful figure, and you could neither present speeches before the assemblies of justice in the proper manner, nor proclaim anything persuasive or probable, nor advocate a novel proposal on behalf of someone else." What's more, dear Socrates – and don't be angry with me for I am

about to speak with good intentions towards you – doesn't it seem disgraceful to you to be in the predicament I think you are in, along with the rest of those who are in the habit of pressing philosophy too far? For if someone were now to take hold of you, or anyone else of your sort, and cart you off to prison, claiming that you had acted unjustly when you had done nothing wrong, you know that you wouldn't know what to do with yourself. No, you would be dizzy, open-mouthed, not knowing what you should say, and on being brought to court, meeting some lowly, knavish accuser, you would be executed if he wanted the death penalty for you. Yes, indeed, Socrates. "How can this be anything wise, a skill that takes a naturally talented man and makes him worse?", unable either to help himself or to save either himself or anyone else from the utmost dangers, liable to have all his property confiscated by his enemies, living in the city effectively deprived of his rights? And to put it quite crudely, it is possible to slap someone like this across the face and pay no penalty. So, good fellow, heed my entreaty: desist from the practice of refutation. Practise the sweet music of business affairs instead. Practise something that will make you seem intelligent. Leave the subtleties to other people, the nonsensicalities, or fooleries, or whatever they should be called, for these will have you "dwelling in empty halls".²⁸ Do not envy those who engage in these trifling refutations, but men of substance, reputation and other advantages aplenty.

486d

Socrates: Callicles, if my soul happened to be made of gold, do you not think I would be pleased to discover one of those stones with which they test gold, the best one there is? And if I applied the soul to this, and it confirmed to me that my soul had been properly cared for, would I be right to accept that I am, finally, in good condition, or would I still need another test?

Callicles: Why are you asking this question, Socrates?

Socrates: I will tell you right now. I think that this chance encounter with you is an encounter with a god-send of this kind.

Callicles: In what way?

486e

Socrates: I know very well that if you agree with me on the issues about which my soul forms opinions, such agreements then constitute truth itself. For I realise that someone who proposes to test comprehensively whether or not the soul lives aright surely needs to have three qualities, all of which you possess: knowledge, good intentions and frankness. Indeed, I meet many people who are not able to test me because they are not wise like you. There are others who are wise, but they are not prepared to speak the truth to me because they do not care about me, as you do. These two visitors, Gorgias and Polus, despite being wise and being friends of mine, are yet lacking in frankness, and are both more reticent than they need to be. How could they not be? They both ended up in such embarrassment that for shame, each of them dared to contradict themselves in front of a lot of people on issues of the utmost importance. But you possess all those qualities that the others lack, for you have been properly educated, as numerous Athenians would attest, and you are well disposed towards me.

What evidence do I have? I shall tell you. I know, Callicles, that there are four of you who have become associates in wisdom: yourself, Teisander of Aphidnae, Andron, son of Androtion, and Nausicydes of Cholargos.²⁹ And I once heard you deliberating on how far one should pursue the practice of wisdom, and I know that an opinion prevailed among you that went something like this: that you should not be eager to

engage in philosophy in a serious way; instead you encouraged one another to be careful lest you become wise beyond the limit of necessity and get corrupted without noticing it. Now, when I hear you giving me the same advice you give to your own companions, that is enough evidence for me that you are, in truth, well disposed towards me. And, indeed, you yourself assert, and the speech you made a short time ago confirms, that you are able to speak frankly and be devoid of shame. So, it is evident that this is where we stand on these issues. If you come to agree with me on anything in these discussions, the point in question will at that stage have been adequately tested by you and me, and will not need to be subjected to any other test. For you would never have gone along with it, either from lack of wisdom or excessive shame, and, what is more, you would not make the concession to deceive me, for, as you say yourself, you are my friend. Therefore, agreement between you and me will, in fact, already constitute complete truth. But the most sublime enquiry of all concerns the issues over which you rebuked me: the sort of person a man should be, the pursuits he should engage in and how far he should pursue them, both when he is younger and when he is older. Indeed, if I am acting incorrectly in some aspect of my own life, rest assured that I am not going astray deliberately, but through my own ignorance. And since you have begun to correct me, do not give up. Rather show me, satisfactorily, what it is that I should pursue and the manner in which I may acquire it. And if you find me agreeing with you now, and yet sometime later not enacting what was agreed, you should regard me as an utter fool, and never correct me again thereafter because I do not deserve it.

But tell me from the beginning, what do you and Pindar claim that the justice that accords with nature actually involves? Is

it that the stronger carry off the possessions of the weaker by force, that the superior rule over the inferior, and that better men have more than lesser men? Are you saying that justice is something else, or am I recalling this correctly?

488b

Callicles: Yes, that's what I said then, and that's what I say now.

488c

Socrates: And do you refer to superior and stronger as the same? Indeed, I was not really able to understand what precisely you were saying. Are you calling the more powerful people stronger? And should the weaker people obey the stronger, which is what I think you were indicating earlier, since the bigger cities attack the smaller ones in accord with what is just by nature, because they are stronger and more powerful, since the stronger, more powerful and superior are the same? Or is it possible to be superior and yet lesser and weaker, to be stronger and yet in a worse state? Or is the definition of the superior and of the stronger the same? Make this particular distinction for me in a clear manner. Are the superior the stronger, and the more powerful the same, or are they different?

488d

Callicles: But I am telling you clearly that they are the same.

Socrates: In that case, is the multitude not stronger, according to nature, than the individual? And indeed they impose laws upon the individual, as you also said earlier.

Callicles: Of course.

Socrates: So, the laws of the multitude are the laws of the stronger?

Callicles: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Are they, therefore, the laws of the superior folk? For according to your argument, I presume the stronger are

superior.

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: Are their laws not good, by nature, being the laws of the stronger?

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: And do the multitude conventionally believe, as you said already, that it is just to maintain equality, and more base to do injustice than to suffer injustice? Is this the case or is it not? And do not get trapped here and become ashamed like the others. Does the multitude conventionally believe this or not: that it is just to have an equal share and no more, and it is more base to do injustice than to suffer injustice? Do not begrudge me an answer to this, Callicles, so that should you agree with me, I may finally attain certainty through you, seeing that a man who is competent to decide has agreed with me.

488e

Callicles: Well, the multitude at any rate do conventionally believe this.

Socrates: So, it is not only by convention, but also by nature, that doing injustice is more base than suffering injustice, and that the maintenance of equality is just. And so, it is very likely that you were not speaking the truth and your criticism of me was incorrect when you said that nature and convention are opposed, and that I knew this and wreaked havoc in the arguments by referring to convention whenever someone spoke on the basis of nature, and referring to nature when they spoke on the basis of convention.

489b

Callicles: This man will not cease talking nonsense! Tell me, Socrates, are you not ashamed, at your age, to be chasing after words and making out that it is a godsend if someone goes awry in expressing himself? Indeed, do you think I am saying that

being stronger is something different from being superior? Did I not tell you long ago that I declare the superior and stronger to be the same? Or do you think I am saying that if a mob of slaves and people of all sorts were to get together, worthless except perhaps for their physical strength, and these fellows were to make some pronouncements, that such pronouncements would constitute law?

489c

Socrates: So be it, my utterly wise Callicles. Is that your meaning?

Callicles: Yes, very much so.

Socrates: Well, my divine friend, I myself have been guessing for some time that you meant something of this sort by ‘the stronger’, and I am eager to understand clearly what you are saying. For I presume that you do not regard two as superior to one, nor your slaves as superior to you because they are stronger than you. So tell me once more, from the beginning, what precisely you mean by ‘the superior’, since they are not the stronger? And, my wonderful friend, instruct me more gently to begin with, so that I do not leave your school.

489e

Callicles: You are being ironical, Socrates.

Socrates: By Zethus, I am not, Callicles, to refer to the character you invoked just now, when you were being highly ironical towards me. Come on, tell us! Who do you say are the superior?

Callicles: I mean the better.

Socrates: Do you not see that you yourself are uttering words but explaining nothing? Will you not tell us whether by the superior and the stronger you mean the more intelligent, or someone else?

Callicles: Yes, by Zeus, that is what I mean, emphatically so.

490a

Socrates: So, in most cases, according to your argument, one man of intelligence is stronger than ten thousand who are devoid of intelligence, and this man should rule and the others should be ruled, and the ruler should have more than those who are ruled. Yes, this is what I think you wish to say, and I am not trapping you with words, if the one is stronger than the ten thousand.

Callicles: Indeed, that is what I mean. For I believe this is just, by nature: those who are superior and more intelligent rule over, and have more than, the lesser people.

490b

Socrates: Hold it there! What exactly are you saying now? Suppose we are together, in the same place just as we are now, a large gathering with a large common store of food and drink, and suppose we are a mixed group, some strong, others weak. But one of us is more intelligent about these matters as he is a physician, although in all likelihood he would be physically stronger than some but weaker than others. Will this fellow be superior and stronger in these matters, as he is more intelligent about them than we are?

Callicles: Entirely so.

490c

Socrates: Now, should he have more of these provisions than the rest of us because he is superior? Or, in virtue of his authority, should this man distribute them all, and yet obtain no more than anyone else by consuming them and diverting them towards his own person, if he is to avoid paying a penalty? And should some get more while others get less? And if the superior man happens to be more feeble than everyone else, should he get less than everyone else, Callicles? Or does it not work like this, my friend?

490d

Callicles: You keep referring to food and drink and physicians and fooleries, but I am not talking about these.

Socrates: Are you not saying that the more intelligent person is superior? Say yes or no.

Callicles: I am.

Socrates: And should the superior not have more?

Callicles: Not of food and drink though.

Socrates: I understand. But maybe it applies to clothing, and the most accomplished weaver has the largest cloak, and goes about dressed in the utmost variety and finery.

Callicles: What has clothing got to do with this?

490e

Socrates: But in relation to shoes it is obvious that the man who is most intelligent in this area, the utterly superior man, should have more. The cobbler should walk about shod in the grandest and greatest number of shoes.

Callicles: Why mention shoes? You are talking persistent nonsense!

Socrates: Well, if that is not the sort of thing you mean, then it is probably something like this. For instance, a man of farming stock, intelligent with respect to the land, noble and good, this fellow should probably have more seeds and use as much seed as he possibly can on his own land.

Callicles: You keep on saying the same things, Socrates!

Socrates: Not only that, Callicles, but also in relation to the same issues.

491a

Callicles: Yes, by the gods, you are absolutely always talking about cobblers, clothes-cleaners, cooks and physicians – you never stop – as if these had anything to do with the argument.

Socrates: So, why will you not say who it relates to? What is it that the superior, more intelligent man has more of, and justly so? Or will you neither accept what I am suggesting, nor propose anything yourself?

Callicles: But I have been saying this for quite some time. Firstly, by those who are superior, I mean neither cobblers nor cooks, but those who are intelligent in relation to the affairs of the city and the manner in which it may be well administered. And they are not merely intelligent, but also courageous, competent to bring their plans to completion without faltering through softness of soul.

491b

Socrates: Do you see, utterly superior Callicles, that your accusation against me is not the same as my accusation against you? You claim that I am always saying the same things, and you censure me for this. But I make the opposite accusation of you, that you never say the same things in relation to the same issues, but one moment you define the superior and stronger as the more powerful, then again as the more intelligent. And now you arrive holding an alternative view, some more courageous people are proposed by you as the stronger and superior. But, good fellow, tell me once and for all, who exactly do you say are superior and stronger, and in what respect?

491c

Callicles: But I have already said that they are the men who are intelligent in relation to the affairs of the city, and who are courageous. For it is fitting for these people to rule the cities, and that is what justice is. These people have more than the others. The rulers have more than the ruled.

491d

Socrates: But what about themselves, my friend? Are they ruling or being ruled?

Callicles: What do you mean?

Socrates: I mean each one ruling himself. Or do you think there is no need for someone to rule himself, but only to rule others?

Callicles: What do you mean by ruling himself?

Socrates: Nothing contrived, just what most people mean: being sound-minded, master of himself, ruling over pleasures and desires within himself.

Callicles: How innocent of you. You are saying that the foolish people are the sound-minded people.

491e

Socrates: How could I be? Anyone can see that that is not what I am saying.

Callicles: It certainly is, Socrates! For how could a person become happy whilst in slavery to anyone else at all? No, I will speak frankly now, and tell you what is noble and just according to nature. Anyone who would live rightly should allow his own desires to be as great as possible and not restrain them, but be competent to minister unto them when they are at their utmost, through courage and intelligence, and satisfy them with whatever the desire of the moment is for. But in my view, most people are unable to do this, and so out of shame they criticise people of this sort, concealing their own impotence. And, as I said earlier, they claim that this lack of restraint is base, enslaving the naturally superior men. Being unable themselves to attain fulfilment of their desires, they praise sound-mindedness and justice on account of their own cowardice. Yet for men who, from the very outset, are either sons of kings or are themselves naturally competent to secure some authority, be it a tyranny or a power-group, what in truth could be more base and ignoble for these men than sound-mindedness and justice? When they are allowed the benefit of good things with no interference from anyone, what could be worse than they themselves imposing a master on

themselves – the law, word and censure of the majority of men? Or how could they avoid becoming wretched on account of this ‘benefit’ of justice and sound-mindedness, whereby they bestow no more upon their friends than upon their enemies, even though they are ruling in their own city? But in truth, Socrates – since you claim to pursue the truth – the fact of the matter is that luxury, lack of restraint and freedom, provided they have support, constitute excellence and happiness, while all else, the niceties and the unnatural contrivances of humanity, are foolishness, and of no value.

492d

Socrates: Callicles, the frankness with which you tackle the argument is not devoid of nobility. Indeed, you are now stating clearly what others are thinking, but they are reluctant to express this. So, I ask you not to relent in any way, so that the manner in which a person should live may actually become evident. Now tell me, do you say that the desires should not be restrained if a man is to be as he should be? Rather, letting them develop to the utmost, should he prepare satisfaction for them from any source whatsoever, and does this constitute excellence?

492e

Callicles: Yes. That is what I declare.

Socrates: So, it would not be correct to say that those who are in need of nothing are happy?

Callicles: No, for in that case stones and corpses would be happiest.

Socrates: But surely the life you are describing is awful too. In fact, I would not be surprised if Euripides is speaking the truth, in the lines where he says,

Who knows whether being alive is being dead

*And being dead is being alive.*³⁰

And we perhaps are actually dead, for I heard at some stage, from one of the wise, that we are now dead and the body is our tomb, while this part of the soul in which the desires reside is prone to persuasion and to fluctuation back and forth. And some subtle person – perhaps a Sicilian or an Italian – told a story involving a play upon the words, and due to its credulous and persuadable nature he called it a pitcher, and the mindless people he called ‘uninitiated’, and the part of the soul of the mindless people in which the desires reside, the unrestrained and the unconfined part of it, he compared to a leaking pitcher because of its insatiability. Now, this fellow, in contrast to yourself, Callicles, indicates that these uninitiated people are the most wretched of those in Hades, by which he means ‘the unseen’, and they carry water to their leaky pitcher in another such leaky vessel, a sieve. And according to the person who told me this, he means that the sieve is the soul, and he likened the soul of the mindless people to a sieve because it is leaking, since due to disbelief and forgetfulness it is unable to retain anything.

Now, this is all somewhat strange, yet it does indicate what I wish to prove to you, if I am able, in order to persuade you to change your stance and choose an orderly life, ever content and satisfied with what you have at any moment, rather than a life without restraint, and devoid of satisfaction. Well, am I persuading you, and are you changing to the view that the orderly people are happier than those without restraint? Or would you not change your position, even if I were to relate many more stories of this kind?

^{493d}

Callicles: The latter option is truer, Socrates.

Socrates: Come on then, I will relate another image from the same school as this one. Yes, consider whether you are saying something of this sort about the lives of the sound-minded and unrestrained people. It is as if two men each have a number of pitchers, and in one case they are sound and full of wine, honey and milk. And there are many others with a variety of contents, but the supply of each of these is meagre and hard to come by and is made available with considerable exertion and difficulty. In one case, once filled, the man neither replenishes them nor worries about them, and on account of this he is at peace. But in the other case, as with the other man, the supply can be made available but it is hard to come by, and the vessels are leaky and unsound, so he is compelled to fill them constantly, night and day, or suffer intense pain. Now, since this is what their lives are like, would you say that the life of the unrestrained person is happier than that of the orderly person? In saying all this, do I persuade you at all to go along with the view that the orderly life is better than the unrestrained life, or are you unpersuaded?

494a

Callicles: You do not persuade me, Socrates. For one man no longer has any pleasure at all once he has been filled, but as I said just now that is to live like a stone, no longer experiencing delight or tribulation once you have been filled up. But living a life of pleasure involves taking, inasmuch as you can.

494b

Socrates: But if a lot is to flow in, mustn't a lot flow out? And mustn't the holes for the outflow be of considerable size?

Callicles: Very much so.

Socrates: In that case, you are describing the life of a gull rather than a corpse or a stone. Are you referring to something like being hungry, and eating when you are hungry?

Callicles: I am.

Socrates: Or being thirsty, and drinking when you are thirsty?

Callicles: That's what I mean, and having all the other desires, and delighting in being able to satisfy them and live happily.

494c

Socrates: Excellent, well said! Proceed as you have begun and take care that you suffer no shame. And it seems I must exhibit no shame either. So, tell me firstly whether someone who is itchy, and is scratching with unlimited scope for scratching, who spends his life scratching, is living happily.

Callicles: How strange you are, Socrates, an out and out rabble-rouser!

Socrates: Yes, indeed, Callicles, and I shocked Polus and Gorgias and made them ashamed, but you should be neither shocked nor ashamed, for you are courageous. So, just answer the question.

Callicles: In that case, I declare that the scratcher also lives pleasantly.

Socrates: Since he lives pleasantly, does he also live happily?

Callicles: Certainly.

494d

Socrates: Is this so if he only scratches his head? What if I ask you about other parts? Consider how you would reply, Callicles, if someone were to ask about all the parts in turn, working down from there. And what about the ultimate consideration in all this, the life of the catamites?³¹ Is this not terrible, shameful and wretched? Or will you dare to say that these fellows are happy provided they have unlimited access to what they want?

494e

Callicles: Are you not ashamed at leading our discussion onto topics of this kind, Socrates?

Socrates: Am I the one who led us there, my noble friend? Or was it the person who said, in such absolute terms, that those who enjoy pleasure, regardless of how they enjoy it, are happy, and who did not distinguish between good pleasures and bad ones? But you should also declare now whether you are saying that pleasure and good are the same, or that there are some pleasures that are not good.

495a

Callicles: Well, since my responses will be contradictory if I say they are different, I declare that they are the same.

Socrates: You are undermining your opening assertions, Callicles, and will no longer be investigating things that are, in an adequate manner, along with me if you actually speak contrary to your own opinions.

Callicles: The same goes for you, Socrates.

495b

Socrates: Then if I am actually doing this, neither of us is acting correctly. But, blessed man, consider the possibility that the good may not be this unqualified gratification. Indeed, if this is how matters stand, then the many shameful conclusions I hinted at just now, and many more besides, must follow.

Callicles: That's what you think anyway, Socrates.

Socrates: And do you really hold to those views, Callicles?

Callicles: I do.

495c

Socrates: So, should we tackle this argument on the basis that you are serious about it?

Callicles: Yes, very much so.

Socrates: Come on then, since that is what you think. Make the following distinctions for me. I presume there is something you refer to as knowledge?

Callicles: There is.

Socrates: And did you not say just now that courage is something that may accompany knowledge?

Callicles: I said so indeed.

Socrates: So, on the basis that courage is different from knowledge, you referred to two things?

Callicles: Most emphatically.

Socrates: What about this? Are pleasure and knowledge the same or different?

495d

Callicles: Different of course, O wisest of men.

Socrates: And is courage different from pleasure?

Callicles: How could it not be?

Socrates: Come then, make sure we remember that Callicles of Acharnae declares pleasure and good to be the same, but knowledge and courage to be different from one another, and from the good.

Callicles: And Socrates of Alopecce disagrees with us on this. Or does he agree?

495e

Socrates: He does not agree, and I do not think Callicles will agree either once he sees himself correctly. Indeed, tell me. Do you not believe that those who are acting well are characterised by the opposite quality to those who act badly?

Callicles: I do.

Socrates: Well then, since these are opposite to one another, must not the same consideration apply to them as applies to being healthy and to being ill? For a person is obviously not healthy and ill at the same time, nor is he rid of health and

illness at the same time.

Callicles: What do you mean?

496a

Socrates: For example, take any part of the body you wish, and consider it. Can a person get the disease of the eyes called ophthalmia?

Callicles: Of course he can.

Socrates: And the same eyes are obviously not, simultaneously, healthy.

Callicles: Not at all.

Socrates: But what happens when he is rid of the ophthalmia? Is he also rid of the health at that stage, and does he end up rid of both at the same time?

Callicles: Not in the least.

496b

Socrates: Yes, I think that would be a strange and illogical outcome. Is that so?

Callicles: Very much so.

Socrates: Rather, I believe we acquire either of them and lose them in turn.

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: Does not the same go for strength and weakness?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: And for swiftness and slowness?

Callicles: Certainly.

496c

Socrates: And for anything good and for happiness, and the opposites of these, anything bad and wretchedness. Are they

acquired in turn, and are we quit of either of them in turn?

Callicles: That is totally obvious.

Socrates: So, if we were to find any qualities that a person is quit of and possesses at the same time, it is obvious that these would not be the good and the bad. Do we agree on this? And give this very serious consideration before you reply.

Callicles: But I couldn't agree more!

Socrates: Let us go back to what we agreed upon earlier. Did you say that hunger was pleasant or unpleasant? I am referring just to the hunger.

Callicles: I say it is unpleasant, but to eat when hungry is pleasant.

496d

Socrates: So do I. I understand. However, the hunger itself is unpleasant, is it not?

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: Does not the same go for thirst?

Callicles: Very much so.

Socrates: Now, should I ask you even more questions, or do you agree that all lack and desire is unpleasant?

Callicles: I do. Stop asking.

Socrates: So be it. And do you agree that to drink when thirsty is pleasant?

Callicles: I do.

Socrates: So, this formulation 'when thirsty' obviously means 'when in pain'.

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: And the drinking is both the satisfaction of the lack, and a pleasure.

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: Therefore, whilst the drinking takes place, you say there is enjoyment.

Callicles: Certainly.

Socrates: When you are thirsty anyway.

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: And experiencing pain?

Callicles: Yes.

496e

Socrates: Now, are you aware of the conclusion that whenever you say that you drink whilst thirsty, you are saying that you experience enjoyment and are in pain simultaneously? Does this not occur at the same time and in the same place, be it in soul or in body? I do not think it makes any difference which it is. Is this the case or is it not?

Callicles: It is.

Socrates: However, you do declare that acting well and acting badly at the same time is impossible.

Callicles: Yes, I do.

Socrates: And yet you have agreed that it is possible to have enjoyment whilst experiencing displeasure.

Callicles: Apparently.

497a

Socrates: So, enjoyment is not ‘acting well’, nor is displeasure ‘acting badly’, and consequently pleasure turns out to be different from the good.

Callicles: I don't understand these wise utterances of yours, Socrates.

Socrates: You do understand but you are playing the simpleton, Callicles. Just move on to the next point anyway so that you may know how wise you are to admonish me. Does not each of us cease being thirsty and simultaneously cease being pleased by the drinking?

Callicles: I do not know what you mean.

497b

Gorgias: Don't be like that, Callicles, but answer him for our sake too so that the arguments may be concluded.

Callicles: But Socrates is always like this, Gorgias. He asks petty, worthless questions, and refutes people.

Gorgias: But why does it matter to you? It is not really up to you to assess their worth, Callicles, but to allow Socrates to carry out his refutation in any way he pleases.

497c

Callicles: Well, since that is what Gorgias thinks, ask your petty, restrictive questions.

Socrates: You are blessed, Callicles, that you have been initiated into the Great Mysteries prior to the Lesser ones.³² I did not realise that this was permitted. Now, answer the question from where you left off. Does not each of us cease being thirsty and simultaneously cease experiencing pleasure?

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: In that case, is there cessation of hunger and the other desires, and cessation of pleasures simultaneously?

Callicles: This is the case.

497d

Socrates: Therefore, there is a simultaneous cessation of the pains and the pleasures?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: However, as you have agreed, there is not a simultaneous cessation of whatever is good and whatever is bad. But do you not agree now?

Callicles: I agree. So what?

Socrates: Then, whatever is good, my friend, turns out not to be the same as whatever is pleasant, nor is what is bad the same as what is unpleasant. For in one case there is simultaneous cessation, and in the other case there is not, because they are different. So, how could whatever is pleasant be the same as whatever is good, or the unpleasant be the same as whatever is bad?

But consider it in the following manner if you prefer, for I do not think you agree based on this approach. Look at it this way. Do you not call good people good, due to the presence of goods, just as you call those to whom beauty is present, beautiful?

497e

Callicles: I do.

Socrates: What about this? Do you refer to the unintelligent and cowards as good men? Well, you did not do so earlier anyway; rather, you said the good were the courageous and intelligent. Or do you not refer to these men as good?

Callicles: I certainly do.

Socrates: What about this? Have you ever seen an unintelligent child being delighted?

Callicles: I have.

Socrates: And have you ever yet seen an unintelligent man being delighted?

Callicles: I think I have, but what about it?

498a

Socrates: Nothing, just answer.

Callicles: I have seen this.

Socrates: And does someone possessed of intelligence experience pain and delight?

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: But who experiences delight and pain to the greatest extent, the intelligent or the foolish?

Callicles: Well, I don't think they differ very much.

Socrates: That will do. And have you ever seen a cowardly man in battle?

Callicles: Of course.

Socrates: What about the withdrawal of the enemy? Which of them seemed to you to be most delighted, the cowards or the courageous?

498b

Callicles: Both, in my view, but perhaps the cowards delight more, or else they are nearly equal.

Socrates: That makes no difference. So, the cowards are delighted too?

Callicles: Intensely so.

498c

Socrates: The fools too, so it seems.

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: And at the approach of the enemy, do the cowardly alone experience pain? Or do the courageous do so too?

Callicles: Both.

Socrates: To a similar extent?

Callicles: Perhaps the cowardly experience it more.

Socrates: But do they not experience more delight at the withdrawal?

Callicles: Perhaps.

Socrates: Then according to you, the foolish and the intelligent, the cowardly and the brave, experience pain and delight to a similar extent, although the cowardly experience them to a greater extent than the brave?

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: However, the intelligent and courageous are good, while the cowardly and foolish are bad?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: Then the good and the bad experience delight and pain to a similar extent?

Callicles: I agree.

498d

Socrates: So, are the good people and the bad people good and bad to a similar extent? Or are the bad people even more good?

Callicles: By Zeus, I do not know what you are saying.

Socrates: Do you not know that you are saying that the good are good by the presence of goods, and the bad are bad by the presence of what is bad? And that the goods are the pleasures, and what is bad are the displeasures?

Callicles: I do.

Socrates: Are not the goods, the pleasures, present to those who are experiencing delight, if they are actually experiencing delight?

Callicles: Obviously.

Socrates: And since goods are present, are not those who experience delight good?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: What about this? Are not bad things, pains, present to those who experience displeasure?

Callicles: Yes, they are present.

Socrates: And yet you think that the bad people are bad due to the presence of what is bad. Or do you no longer say so?

Callicles: I do.

Socrates: So, those who experience delight are good, while those who experience displeasure are bad.

Callicles: Entirely so.

498e

Socrates: Those who experience these to a greater extent are so to a greater extent. Those who experience these to a lesser extent are so to a lesser extent. Those who experience these to a similar extent are so to a similar extent.

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: Now, do you not claim that the intelligent men and the fools, the cowardly and the courageous, are delighted and pained to a similar extent, or that the cowardly experience them even more?

Callicles: I do.

499a

Socrates: Well, please sum up what follows from all that we have agreed, along with me. For they say it is well to state and investigate anything exalted twice or even thrice. We say that the intelligent and courageous man is good. Is this so?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: But the foolish and cowardly man is bad?

Callicles: Entirely so.

Socrates: And what is more, the man who experiences delight is good?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: And the man who experiences displeasure is bad?

Callicles: Necessarily.

Socrates: So, the good and the bad experience displeasure and delight to a similar extent, but perhaps the bad person experiences them more?

Callicles: Yes.

499b

Socrates: Does it not turn out that the bad man is good and bad to a similar extent as the good man, or is even more good? Do not these, and those former consequences, follow once someone declares that pleasures and good are the same? Is this not necessarily the case, Callicles?

Callicles: Socrates, I have been listening to you for some time now, making concessions and reflecting that if someone grants you anything at all, even in jest, you hold onto it in delight just like a child. Do you really think that I, or any other man whatsoever, does not realise that some pleasures are better and some are worse?

499c

Socrates: My, my, Callicles. How clever you are, and how like a child you treat me, deceiving me by saying at one moment that this is how matters stand, and the next moment that the same matters stand otherwise. And yet, I had not expected at the outset that I would be intentionally deceived by you since you are my friend. But now I have been played false, and it seems necessary for me, as the old saying goes, 'to make the best of what is there' and to accept what you have given me. And, indeed, what you are now saying, it seems, is that certain pleasures are good, while others are bad. Is this so?

499d

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: Well, are the beneficial pleasures good, while the harmful ones are bad?

Callicles: Certainly.

Socrates: And do the beneficial ones bring about something good, the harmful ones something bad?

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: So, do you mean, for instance, in the case of the bodily pleasures we referred to just now, pleasures of eating and drinking, that those producing health or strength or some other physical excellence in the body are good, while those producing the opposite effects to these are bad?

499e

Callicles: Certainly.

Socrates: Does not the same go for pains – some are useful while others are evil?

Callicles: Inevitably.

Socrates: Should the useful pleasures and pains be selected and enacted?

Callicles: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: But not the evil ones?

Callicles: Obviously.

Socrates: Indeed, you may recall that it seemed to us, Polus and I, that everything must somehow be enacted for the sake of whatever is good. Do you also share this view, that the aim of all actions is the good, and all else must be enacted for the sake of that, rather than the other way around? Are you also voting with us, as a third vote?

500a

Callicles: I am.

Socrates: So, everything else, pleasures included, must be enacted for the sake of whatever is good, rather than enacting whatever is good for the sake of the pleasures.

Callicles: Certainly.

500b

Socrates: Now, does it belong to every man to select what sort of pleasures are good and what sort are bad, or is a skilled person required in each case?

Callicles: A skilled person is required.

Socrates: Then let us go on, recalling what I was saying to Polus and Gorgias. I said, if you remember, that there are processes that go as far as pleasure and furnish pleasure alone and do not recognise the better and the worse, and there are processes which do recognise what is good and what is bad. And in the category concerned with pleasure, I placed cookery a practice, but not a skill. In the category concerned with the good, I placed the skill of medicine. And in the name of friendship, Callicles, do not presume that you need to play games with me, and do not respond at random and contrary to your opinions, and do not, again, treat my utterances as some sort of game playing. Indeed,

our discussions are concerned with a topic on which even a man of minute intelligence should be most serious, the manner in which a person should live. Is it the one to which you exhort me: namely, engaging in these manly activities, speaking in public, practising rhetoric, and engaging in the mode of politics that you people practise these days? Or is it the life spent in philosophy? And how exactly does this life differ from the other one? Now, perhaps it is best to distinguish them as I tried to do before, and once we have made the distinction and agreed with one another, then consider if these are indeed two ways of life, how they differ from one another, and which of the two we should live by. But perhaps you do not understand what I mean yet.

500d

Callicles: Not at all.

Socrates: Then I shall relate it to you more clearly. Since we have agreed, you and I, that there is a good and there is a pleasant, that the pleasant is different from the good, that there is a study and process of acquisition belonging to both, one pursuing the pleasant, the other pursuing the good. But first you should either agree or disagree with me about this. Do you agree?

Callicles: I agree with this.

Socrates: Come on, then. You should agree with me fully on the points I made to our friends here, provided I seemed to you to be speaking the truth at the time. I think I said that cookery did not seem to me to be a skill, but a practice. But in the case of medicine, I said that it considers the nature of whomever it cares for and the motive for whatever it enacts, and is able to give an account of each of these. But the other one cares for pleasure and is directed entirely to that, going about it in an utterly unskilled manner. It provides pleasures without considering either the nature of the pleasure or the motivation

for it, utterly irrational, scarcely bothering to count classifications, retaining, through habit and experience, only a memory of what usually happens. Now, in the first place, do you think these have been adequately described? Or do there also seem to be any processes of this kind concerning the soul, some of which involve a skill and possess a certain foresight of what is best for the soul, and others which make light of this, while they, for their part, consider, as in the former case, only the pleasure of the soul and the manner in which this may be brought about, neither investigating which of the pleasures is better or worse, nor studying anything except the gratification alone, be it better or be it worse? Indeed, Callicles, I think these processes exist, and I declare that this sort of thing is flattery in relation to the body or in relation to the soul, or anything whose pleasure one may care for, without having any concern for the better or the worse. Anyway, do you subscribe to the same opinion as we do on these issues, or do you disagree?

501c

Callicles: I don't agree, but I am going along with this so that you may conclude the discussion, and so that I may gratify Gorgias here.

501d

Socrates: And does this apply to a single soul, but not to two or many?

Callicles: No, it applies to two or many.

Socrates: Is it not also possible to gratify a gathering of souls, all at the same time, without considering what is best?

Callicles: Yes, I think so.

Socrates: Now, can you say what particular activities bring this about? But if you like, it is better that as I ask questions, you agree if the suggestion seems to you to belong to that category, but otherwise disagree. And first, let us consider flute-playing.

Does this not seem to you, Callicles, to be an activity of this kind, one that pursues only our pleasure and thinks of nothing else?

501e

Callicles: It seems so to me anyway.

Socrates: Does not the same go for all activities of that sort, such as playing the cithara in competitions?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: What about the instruction of the dramatic choruses or the composition of poetic verses? Is it not obvious to you that they are also like this? Or do you think Cinesias, son of Meles,³³ gives some consideration to how he may say the kind of thing that will enable his hearers to become better people, or instead how he is going to gratify the crowd of spectators?

502a

Callicles: Obviously the latter, Socrates, in the case of Cinesias anyway.

Socrates: What about his father, Meles? Do you think he sang to the cithara with a view to what is best, or did the man even consider what is most pleasant? Indeed, his singing inflicted pain upon the spectators. But think about this. Does it seem to you that all singing to the cithara and all composition of poetic verses have been devised for the sake of pleasure?

Callicles: I think so.

502b

Socrates: But what about the solemn one herself, the wonder that is the composition of tragic verses? What is she intent upon? What, in your view, is her endeavour and intention? Is it only to gratify the spectators? Or in the case where something is pleasant and gratifying to them, but evil, does she engage in a struggle so as not to utter this? And if something happens to be unpleasant but beneficial, will she speak and sing this whether

it delights them or not? Which of these two approaches does the composition of tragic verses seem to you to adopt?

502c

Callicles: Well, Socrates, it is obviously the latter, the one that is most intent on pleasure and the gratification of the spectators.

Socrates: Did we not say just now that this sort of thing is flattery, Callicles?

Callicles: Certainly.

Socrates: Come now, if someone were to strip poetic composition of all its melody, rhythm and metre, would the residue turn out to be nothing but words?

Callicles: Necessarily.

Socrates: Are not those words spoken to a considerable crowd and to the populace?

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: So, poetic skill is a kind of public speaking.

502d

Callicles: So it appears.

502e

Socrates: Would it not be rhetorical public speaking, or do you think that the poets do not engage in rhetoric in the theatres?

Callicles: I think they do.

Socrates: So, we have now discovered a type of rhetoric directed to a kind of populace that consists of women and children alike, of men both enslaved and free, a rhetoric we do not greatly admire, for we assert that it is based on flattery.

Callicles: Very much so.

Socrates: So be it. But what about the rhetoric directed to the Athenian populace and the other assemblies of free men in the cities? What exactly are we to make of it? Do the rhetoricians seem to you to speak always with regard to what is best, working out how the citizens may be as good as possible on account of their speeches? Or do these fellows aim at the gratification of the citizens, belittle the common good for the sake of their own private interest, and associate with the populace as though they were children, merely trying to gratify them but thinking nothing of whether they will be better or worse as a result of all this?

503a

Callicles: This is no longer a simple question. There are some who say what they say out of concern for the citizens, but there are others of the sort you are describing.

Socrates: That is sufficient. For if there are indeed two aspects to this, then I presume that one would be flattery and a disgraceful public speaking, while the other would be noble, contriving that the souls of the citizens be as good as possible and constantly striving to utter what is best, regardless of whether it be more pleasant or less pleasant to those who hear it. But this is a rhetoric you have never yet seen. Or if you are able to mention any rhetorician of this kind, why have you never told me who he is?

503b

Callicles: But, by Zeus, I cannot mention anyone to you, not among the contemporary rhetoricians anyway.

Socrates: What about the older generation? Can you name anyone, on account of whom the Athenians are reputed to have become better after that person began speaking in public? Indeed, I do not know who the person is.

503c

Callicles: Is that so? Do you not hear people say that Themistocles was a good man, Cimon too, and Miltiades, and Pericles himself, who died recently, whom you yourself have heard?

Socrates: Yes, Callicles, if what you described earlier is true excellence, the satisfaction of your own desires and those of others. However, if this is not the case, and instead, as in the earlier discussion, we are compelled to agree that the satisfaction of some desires make a person better and these should be fulfilled, while others make him worse and should not be fulfilled, and there is a skill involved in this as we thought, can you still claim that any of those four men turned out to be someone with this sort of skill?

503d

Callicles: I cannot find any basis for saying so.

Socrates: But if you search properly you will find one. So, we should examine this in a calm manner and see whether any of these men prove to be a person of this kind. Come on, would not the good man, whose speech is aimed at what is best, say what he says not at random, but with something particular in view? Indeed, he is just like the other artificers, each looking to their own work, selecting whatever they bring to bear not at random, but in such a way as to give a particular form to whatever they are working on. Take, for example, painters, builders, shipwrights and all the other artisans, any one of them you want. See how he places whatever he places in a particular order, and compels this to fit with that and to be in harmony until he has wrought the entire into an organised and orderly entity. And the same goes for the other artificers and those we mentioned earlier, the trainers and physicians who are concerned with the body, and presumably order and organise the body. Do we agree that this is the case or not?

504a

Callicles: Let this be the case.

Socrates: Would a household possessing organisation and order be effective, and would a disorganised one be degenerate?

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: Does not the same go for a ship?

504b

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: And do we also say this about our own bodies?

Callicles: Very much so.

Socrates: And what about the soul? Will it be effective when possessed of disorder or when possessed of some organisation and order?

Callicles: Based on what was said earlier, it is also necessary to accept this.

Socrates: Now, what is the name of the condition that arises in the body from organisation and order?

Callicles: You probably mean health and strength.

504c

Socrates: I do. But what about the condition engendered in the soul from organisation and order? Try to find its name and state it as you did in the other case.

Callicles: Why don't you state it yourself, Socrates?

Socrates: Well, I shall say it if that is more pleasing to you, and you should agree if you think I am speaking truly. And, if not, you should refute me and you should not yield to me. For I think that the name of this organisation of the body is 'healthiness' and, from this, health arises in it, and so do the other excellences of the body. Is this the case or is it not?

Callicles: It is.

504d

Socrates: On the other hand, I think that the names of the organisation and order of the soul are lawfulness and law, and from these it becomes lawful and orderly, and these conditions are justice and sound-mindedness. Do you agree or not?

Callicles: Be it so.

Socrates: Then, looking towards these, this rhetorician who is skilled and good also brings the speeches he delivers, and all his actions too, to bear upon the souls. And when he bestows a gift, he will bestow it, and when he confiscates something, he will confiscate it, with his mind ever intent upon how justice may arise in the souls of his fellow citizens and injustice may be banished; how sound-mindedness may be engendered and indiscipline banished; how excellence in general may be engendered and evils done away with. Do you agree or not?

504e

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: Indeed, what is the benefit, Callicles, in giving a person, sick in body, in a degenerate condition, a lot of food – even the most pleasant – or drink, or anything else that does not benefit him one bit more and, on the contrary, may rightly be said to benefit him less? Is this so?

505a

Callicles: Be it so.

Socrates: For in my view it is not advantageous for a person to live with degeneracy of the body, since it is necessary under those circumstances to live in a degenerate manner. Or is this not so?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: Do not the physicians, for the most part, allow a person to satisfy his desires, such as eating as much as he wants when he is hungry and drinking when thirsty, as long as the

person is healthy? However, when he is ill, they hardly allow him to be sated by the objects of his desire at all. Do you also agree with this?

505b

Callicles: I do.

Socrates: And in the case of the soul, excellent man, is there not the same tendency? As long as it is corrupt, foolish, undisciplined, unjust and unholy, it needs to be shut away from the desires and not be allowed to engage in any other activities apart from those whereby it will be made better. Do you agree or not?

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: For presumably that is what is better for the soul itself?

Callicles: Very much so.

Socrates: Now, is the shutting away from what is desired equivalent to discipline?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: So, being disciplined is better for the soul than the indiscipline which you were advocating a moment ago.

505c

Callicles: I don't know what you are talking about, Socrates. Just ask someone else.

Socrates: This man cannot put up with being helped and undergoing for himself the process with which our discussion is concerned – being disciplined.

Callicles: Nor does anything you are saying interest me, and I gave you these answers to oblige Gorgias.

Socrates: So be it. What shall we do now? We are cut off in mid-argument.³⁴

Callicles: Decide for yourself.

Socrates: But they say that it is not lawful to leave off, even in the middle of stories. Rather, they should be given a conclusion so that they do not go about without a head. So, you should also answer the remaining questions so that our argument may acquire a head.

505d

Callicles: How forceful you are, Socrates! But if you take my advice you will bid farewell to this argument, or else you should converse with someone else.

Socrates: Well, who else is willing? For we should not leave the argument incomplete.

Callicles: Could you not work through the argument yourself, either speaking on your own behalf or responding to yourself?

Socrates: So that the saying of Epicharmus may be fulfilled in me: “The words that were spoken by two men, I, one man, must rise to delivering.”³⁵ Anyway, it seems to be absolutely necessary, so that is how we should do it then. I, for one, think that we should possess a thirst for victory when it comes to knowing what the truth is, and what is false, in relation to the matters we are discussing. Indeed, it is a good, common to everyone, that this be made manifest. Now, I shall proceed with the argument based upon how it seems to me. However, if any of you think I am agreeing with myself contrary to things that are, you should pull me up and refute me. For I am not really saying what I am saying as someone who has some comprehensive knowledge. No, I am seeking along with you, and so if someone who contradicts me proves to have a point, I shall be the first to go along with him. Yet, I am asking all this assuming that the argument should be brought to a conclusion. However, if you do not wish to do so, let us bid it farewell at this stage and go our ways.

506a

Gorgias: Well, Socrates, I don't think we need to go our ways, but you need to work through the argument, and it appears to me that the others think so too. Indeed, I myself wish to hear you going through the remaining issues by yourself.

506b

Socrates: But of course, Gorgias, so do I, although I would gladly have conversed further with Callicles here until I had given him the statement of Amphion in response to that of Zethus. However, Callicles, since you are not willing to conclude the argument, you should at least interject as you hear me if you think I am expressing anything badly, and should you refute me, I shall not be angry with you as you were with me. Instead, you will be inscribed as my greatest benefactor.

506c

Callicles: Speak on, good man, and finish it yourself.

Socrates: Then hear me as I take up the argument from the beginning.

Are the pleasant and the good the same?

They are not the same, as Callicles and I have agreed.

Is the pleasant enacted for the sake of the good, or the good for the sake of the pleasant?

The pleasant for the sake of the good.

Is pleasure that from which, when it has arisen, we are pleased? And is good that from which, when it is present, we are good?

Very much so.

But of course we are good, and so too is everything else that is good, from some excellence that arises.

I think this is necessarily the case, Callicles.

And yet the excellence of anything, of an implement, a body, or indeed a soul, or of every living creature, does not best arise in a random manner, but through organisation, correctness, and a skill that has been assigned to each. Is this the case?

Yes, I agree.

So, is the excellence of each an arrangement and an ordering due to organisation?

I would say so.

Then each of the things that are is rendered good by a certain order engendered in each, and particular to each.

So it seems to me anyway.

Then is a soul too, possessing its own order, better than a disordered one?

It must be.

But of course, the one possessed of order is orderly?

How could it not be?

And the orderly is sound-minded?

Most necessarily.

So, the sound-minded soul is good.

Now, dear friend, Callicles, I have nothing else to say in opposition to all this. However, if you have, teach it.

507a

Callicles: Speak on, my good man.

Socrates: Well, I say that if the good soul is sound-minded, the one affected by the opposite of sound-mindedness is bad, and that is the one devoid of sound-mindedness and discipline.

Very much so.

And, indeed, the sound-minded person would perform actions that are appropriate in relation both to gods and men, for those who perform inappropriate actions would not be exercising sound-mindedness.

This is necessarily the case.

And, indeed, in relation to men, those who are performing appropriate actions would be performing just actions, and in relation to gods, holy actions, and the person who performs just and holy actions is necessarily just and holy.

This is so.

Then again, he is necessarily courageous too, for it is not the part of a sound-minded man either to pursue or flee from

whatever is not appropriate. No, he should flee from and pursue whatever he ought to flee from or pursue, be they actions, persons, pleasures or pains, and endure steadfastly wherever he ought. Consequently, it is very necessary, Callicles, just as we were explaining, that the sound-minded man, being just, courageous and holy, be a perfectly good man. And the good man, whenever he acts, acts well and nobly, and he who acts well must be blessed and happy, while the corrupt man, acting in an evil manner, must be wretched. And this fellow, the undisciplined man whom you were praising, would be in an opposite condition to the sound-minded man.

So, I am setting down these principles in this manner, and I declare that they are true. And if this is true, then someone who wishes to be happy must, it seems, pursue and practise sound-mindedness, and each of us must flee from indiscipline as fast as his feet will carry him. And we should contrive as best we can not to be lacking in any discipline, and if it is lacking, either in ourselves, in any member of our household, in an individual, or in a city, then justice and discipline must be imposed if they are going to be happy. This, in my view anyway, is the vision one should look to in life, and all one's own efforts and those of the city should be directed towards this, the manner in which justice and sound-mindedness will be available to the person who is to be blessed. This is how one should act, not allowing desires to be undisciplined and endeavouring to satisfy them, an endless vexation, living the life of a thief. For a person of this sort would be friendly neither to God nor to another human being, for he is unable to commune, and to anyone devoid of communion there would be no friendship. And the wise declare, Callicles, that communion, friendship, orderliness, sound-mindedness and justice hold heaven and earth, gods and men, together. And

on account of this, my friend, they refer to the whole as an 'order', and not as a 'disorder' or 'indiscipline'. But I think you have not applied your mind to these matters, and although you are wise in this area, you are unaware that geometrical equality is a great power among both gods and men, and so, because you neglect geometry, you think it necessary to practise taking more. So be it. Now, we should either refute this argument so that the happy are not happy due to the acquisition of justice and sound-mindedness, and the wretched are not wretched due to evil, or else, if this argument is true, we should consider the consequences. All those consequences follow, Callicles, the ones you asked if I was serious about, when I said that one should prosecute oneself, one's son and one's friend, if they do anything wrong, and that rhetoric should be used for this. And the ones you thought that Polus conceded due to shame also turn out to be true. Doing injustice, insofar as it is more shameful than suffering injustice, is more base to that extent. And he who intends to be a rhetorician in the proper sense must also be just and knowledgeable in matters of justice, and have knowledge of all aspects of justice. That is what Polus, in turn, stated that Gorgias agreed to out of shame.

Now, having established all this, let us consider the precise issue on which you censure me, and whether or not it is valid to assert that I am unable to assist either myself or any of my friends or family members, or deliver them from extreme dangers: that I am just like an outcast, subject to the whim of any random person who, to use that bold phrase of yours, wishes to slap me across the face, or to confiscate my property, or to expel me from the city, or ultimately to kill me. And according to your argument, to be in such a predicament is the most base condition of all. And although my argument has been stated many times already, there is no

reason not to state it again. I deny, Callicles, that being slapped across the face unjustly is the most base experience possible, nor is having one's body or one's purse picked. No, striking me or cutting me and what belongs to me in an unjust manner is more base and more evil, and, indeed, stealing, enslaving, house-breaking and, in short, any unjust action whatsoever towards me and mine is both more evil and more base for the perpetrator of the injustice than for me, the sufferer of the injustice. Once all this had become evident to us in this way earlier, in the previous discussions, it was fastened and secured by – if it is not too crude an expression – arguments of iron and adamant, or that is how they seem anyway. And if you, or someone more forceful than you, does not break them, anyone who says anything different from what I am now saying will be unable to speak properly. Indeed, my argument is always the same. I myself do not know how these matters stand; however, no one I have ever met, and no one today, is able to say otherwise without being ridiculous.

Now I, for my part, am proposing that this is how matters stand. Yet if this is the case for the doer of injustice, and injustice is the greatest of evils, and even greater than this greatest of evils, if that is possible, is doing injustice without paying a penalty, what assistance should a man, in truth, be able to provide to himself to avoid being ridiculous? Is it not the kind that averts the greatest harm? Yes, this really must be the assistance which it is utterly base not to be able to proffer either to oneself or to one's own friends and family members. The second worst baseness relates to the second worst harm, the third to the third worst, and so on. The beauty of being able to assist against each evil, and the baseness of being unable to assist, are proportional to the natural magnitude of each evil. Is this the case or is it

otherwise, Callicles?

509c

Callicles: It is not otherwise.

Socrates: So, of the two – doing injustice and suffering injustice – we declare doing injustice to be the greatest evil, and suffering injustice to be the lesser. Now, with what should a man be provided so that he may assist himself and obtain both of these benefits, the one that comes from not acting unjustly, and the one that comes from not suffering injustice? Is it a power or a wish? What I mean is this. If he does not wish to suffer injustice, will he not suffer injustice, or if he has been provided with the power of not suffering injustice, will he not suffer it?

509d

Callicles: Well, that's obvious anyway. The power would be needed.

509e

Socrates: And in the case of doing injustice? If he does not wish to act unjustly, is that sufficient to avoid acting unjustly? Or is some power needed for this too, and the provision of some skill which, unless it is learned and practised, he will act unjustly? Why do you not give me an answer to this question anyway, Callicles? Do you think that Polus and I were or were not compelled to agree in the right way in those earlier discussions when we agreed that no one wishes to do injustice, but all those who do injustice do injustice unwillingly?

510a

Callicles: I grant you that this is the case, Socrates, so that the argument may be concluded.

Socrates: Then it seems that a power and a certain skill must be provided for this purpose too, so that we do not act unjustly.

Callicles: Certainly.

Socrates: Now, what precisely is the skill of equipping ourselves to suffer no injustice, or the least possible? Decide whether your view is the same as mine. Indeed, it seems to me that one should either rule in the city oneself, even as a tyrant, or else be an associate of the existing constitution.

510b

Callicles: Observe, Socrates, how willing I am to praise you when you make a good point. Yes, I think that was a very good point.

Socrates: Then decide whether you think this is nicely expressed too. It seems to me that one person is friend to another to the greatest extent possible on the basis stated by the ancients and the wise, 'like unto like'. Do you not think so too?

Callicles: I do.

510c

Socrates: Therefore, wherever a crude and uneducated tyrant is ruler, and someone in the city is much better than this fellow, the tyrant would obviously fear him, and he would never become a friend to the tyrant with his entire mind.

Callicles: This is so.

Socrates: Nor, if someone was far inferior, would that man be his friend either. For the tyrant would despise him, and would never take him seriously as he would a friend.

Callicles: That is also true.

Socrates: There remains only one man deserving of the title 'friend' to such a person, someone of similar character, who censures and applauds the same things and who is willing to be ruled and submit to his rulership. This fellow will wield great power in this city, and no one will treat him unjustly and get away with it. Is this not the case?

510d

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: So, if one of the young people in this city were to think, ‘By what means may I acquire great power, and have no one treat me unjustly?’, the way for him to do so, it seems, is to accustom himself from his very youth to delight in and to detest the same things as the despot, and contrive that he be as like unto that fellow as possible. Is this not so?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: Then, according to your argument, immunity from unjust treatment and great power in the city will have been attained in this case.

Callicles: Very much so.

510e

Socrates: Now, does this also apply to not acting unjustly? Or is this very different, since he is like the ruler who is unjust and wields great power alongside him? Yes, I believe anyway that in this regard his contrivance will be the exact opposite, to be able to do as much injustice as possible and not pay any penalty for acting unjustly. Is this so?

Callicles: Apparently.

Socrates: Therefore the greatest evil will befall him, being corrupted and mutilated in soul, through power and his imitation of the despot.

511a

Callicles: I don’t know how you manage to continually twist the arguments this way and that, Socrates. Do you not realise that this imitator will put anyone who does not imitate the tyrant to death, if he wishes, and confiscate his possessions?

Socrates: I do realise that, good Callicles, unless I am deaf anyway, since I am hearing it constantly from you and from

Polus just now, and from almost everyone else in the city. But you hear me. He will kill him, if he wishes, but as a degenerate person killing a good and noble person.

Callicles: Yes, isn't that what's most annoying?

Socrates: Not to a man possessing intelligence, as the argument indicates. Or do you think that a man should contrive to live for as long as possible, and study those skills that preserve us always from danger, such as the one you also directed me to study, the rhetoric that keeps us safe in courts of law?

511b

Callicles: Yes, by Zeus, and I am giving you sound advice.

511c

Socrates: What about this, best of men? Do you also think the knowledge of swimming is something august?

Callicles: By Zeus, I do not.

Socrates: And yet it does save people from death whenever they end up in the sort of danger where this knowledge is needed. But if you think this is trivial, I will refer you to a more important knowledge than this, the piloting of ships, which saves not only souls, but also bodies and property from extreme dangers, just as rhetoric does. It is unpretentious and orderly, and it does not strike self-important poses as if engaged in some remarkable activity. But having engaged in the same activity as the courtroom advocates, getting you safely from Aegina³⁶ to here, it charges two obols,³⁷ I think. And if it is a journey from Egypt or the Pontus,³⁸ for this enormous service, having given safe passage to everyone I have just mentioned – yourself, your children, your property and your womenfolk – and having landed them in the harbour, it charges two drachmas at the very most. And the person who possesses this skill and has engaged in these activities disembarks and walks about on shore beside his

ship with a modest demeanour. Indeed, he understands enough to figure out that it is unclear which of the passengers he has benefited by not allowing them to be drowned at sea, and which of them he has harmed, knowing that he disembarked them no better either in body or soul than when he embarked them. He figures out, therefore, that on the one hand, if someone afflicted with serious, incurable bodily diseases does not drown, he is wretched because he did not die, and he is not benefited by the pilot. Yet on the other hand, if someone has numerous diseases of something more exalted than the body, namely the soul, and these are incurable, he reckons that this man's life is not worth living and he will not be benefiting this man if he saves him from the sea, or a court-action, or anything else whatsoever. He knows, rather, that it is not better for a degenerate person to be alive, for he must perforce live badly.

For these reasons, it is not conventional for the pilot to give himself airs, even though he does save us. Nor, for that matter, my wonderful friend, does the military mechanic who is sometimes able, no less than the general, not to mention the pilot or anyone else, to save people. Indeed, on occasion he saves entire cities. You do not think he is comparable to a courtroom advocate, do you? And yet, if he were to speak after the manner of you people, Callicles, solemnising his profession, he would bury you with words, proclaiming and extolling the need to become mechanics, setting the other professions at naught, for he would have a plausible argument. But you despise this man and his skill nonetheless, and you would call him 'mechanic' as a term of reproach, and you would not be prepared to give your daughter to his son, nor would you yourself accept that man's daughter. And yet, given the basis on which you praise your own profession, for what just reason do you despise the mechanic and the others

you mentioned just now? I know you would claim to be better, and from better stock. But if 'better' is not what I say it is, and excellence is just saving yourself and your own possessions, regardless of the sort of person you happen to be, then your censure turns out to be laughable, be it of a mechanic or a physician or any other skills that have been devised in order to save people. But, blessed man, look again lest the noble and the good may be something else besides saving and being saved. For he who is truly a man must not be attached to life, and must give up the notion of living for a particular period of time. Rather, having turned these matters over to the god, and given credence to women, who say that one should not flee from fate, he should consider this. In what way may a person best live the span of life that he will live? Should he assimilate himself to the constitution under which he abides? And should you now become as much like the Athenian populace as you can if you are going to be beloved of them, and wield great power in the city? See if there is advantage in this for you and for me, my miraculous friend, so that we do not suffer the fate they impute to those women of Thessaly who pull down the moon,³⁹ and this choice of ours, this power in the city, be at the cost of all that is dearest to us. But if you believe that any person could bestow upon you the sort of skill that would make you extremely powerful in this city, while being unlike its constitution – perhaps better, perhaps worse – then in my view you have not been properly advised, Callicles. For you need to be not just their imitator, but like them in your own nature if you are going to achieve anything genuine in friendship with the Athenian demos, or indeed, by Zeus, with Demos, the son of Ppyrilampes. So, whoever renders you most like unto them will make you a politician, in the way that you want to be a politician, and a rhetorician too. For every populace is delighted by speeches delivered after their own

fashion, but they are troubled by anything alien to this. Do you have anything different to say my friend? Can we say anything against this, Callicles?

513c

Callicles: You seem to me – I do not know how – to be expressing this well, Socrates, but I have experienced what most people experience. I am not entirely persuaded by you.

Socrates: The love of the populace residing in your soul is opposing me, Callicles, but if we consider these same issues more frequently, thoroughly and better, you will be persuaded. But now you should recollect that we said there are two means of caring for anything, be it soul or body. One operates with pleasure as its aim, the other aims for the very best, does not engage in gratification, and is assertive. Is that not how we defined them at the time?

513d

Callicles: Entirely so.

Socrates: Is not the one that aims at pleasure ignoble, amounting to nothing but flattery? Is this so?

Callicles: Be it so, if you wish it so.

Socrates: While the other, whether it happens to be body or soul that we are caring for, intends that it will be as good as possible.⁴⁰

Callicles: Entirely so.

513e

Socrates: Must we therefore take the city and the citizens in hand in this manner and care for them, making the citizens themselves as good as possible? For surely in the absence of this, as we found in our earlier discussions, there is no advantage in bestowing any other service whatsoever when the understanding of those who are going to acquire a lot of money or authority over something, or any other power at all, is not

noble and good. Should we declare that this is so?

Callicles: Entirely so, if it pleases you more.

514a

Socrates: Now, Callicles, suppose that we were embarking upon civic affairs, and we encouraged one another to engage in construction projects involving large structures such as walls, dockyards or temples. Would we need to examine ourselves and find out firstly whether or not we had knowledge of this skill of construction, and from whom we learned it? Would we need to do this or not?

514b

Callicles: Entirely so.

Socrates: And secondly, would we also have to find out whether we had ever constructed any structure at all, privately, either for one of our friends or for ourselves, and whether this structure was beautiful or ugly. And if we found through these deliberations that our teachers had been notable and good, and we had constructed many beautiful structures whilst with our teachers, and many indeed on our own after we left those teachers, under such circumstances it would make sense for us to embark upon public projects. However, if we were able neither to point out our own teachers, nor any structures at all, or a lot of worthless ones, it would then be stupid, I presume, to turn our hands to public projects, or encourage one another to do so. Should we assert that this is a correct formulation or not?

514c

Callicles: Entirely so.

514d

Socrates: Would this not also apply to all other situations where, having embarked upon public service, we might encourage one another to enter public service perhaps as properly qualified physicians, for instance? Presumably we would scrutinise one another – I, you, and you, me – asking,

“Come on, Socrates. By the gods, where does your own body stand in respect of health? Has anyone else, slave or free, ever been quit of disease through the agency of Socrates?” And I think I would make other enquiries of that sort about you. And if we did not find anyone, citizen or stranger, man or woman, who had been improved in body through our agency, by Zeus, Callicles, would it not be laughable, in truth, if human stupidity were to attain such a level that before practising on a private basis, often in a haphazard manner but often working systematically and exercising the skill properly, we were to encourage ourselves and other people of this sort to turn a hand to public service and, as the saying goes, attempt to learn pottery by working on a large vessel? Do you not think it would be stupid to act in this way?

514e

Callicles: I do.

515a

Socrates: But now, best of men, since you have just begun to engage in civic affairs, and since you are encouraging me and censuring me because I am not engaged in this, shall we not scrutinise one another? So come on, has Callicles already made any of our citizens better? Is there anyone who was previously degenerate, unjust, undisciplined and stupid, be he citizen or stranger, slave or free, who became noble and good through the agency of Callicles? Tell me, if anyone scrutinises you on these bases, Callicles, what will you say? What person will you claim to have made better through their association with you? Why are you reluctant to answer if there really is some achievement of yours from your days as a private citizen, before you turned your hand to public service?

515b

Callicles: You have a thirst for victory, Socrates.

Socrates: No, I am not asking out of a thirst for victory, but as someone who truly wishes to know the precise manner in which you think political activity should be conducted among us. Or, once you embark upon civic affairs among us, will you really care for anything else besides the issue of how we citizens may become as good as possible? Have we not agreed several times already that this is what a political man should do? Have we agreed or not? Please answer. I shall answer on your behalf. We have agreed. In that case, if this is the service a good man should furnish to his own city, recollect and tell me now about the men you mentioned a short while ago, Pericles, Cimon, Miltiades and Themistocles. Do you still think these men were good citizens?

515d

Callicles: I do.

Socrates: Then, since they were good, it is obvious that each of them made the citizens better rather than worse. Did they do this or not?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: In that case, when Pericles began speaking in the Assembly, were the Athenians worse than when he delivered his final speeches?

Callicles: Probably.

Socrates: Surely, best of men, this is not probably, but necessarily the case, based on what we have agreed, if, in fact, Pericles was, at any rate, a good citizen.

515e

Callicles: What about it?

Socrates: Nothing. But tell me this as well. Do the Athenians claim to have become better through the agency of Pericles, or quite the contrary, to have been corrupted by the man? Indeed,

what I hear anyway is that Pericles turned the Athenians into lazy, cowardly, blabbering money-lovers by first instituting paid public service.

Callicles: You have heard all this from admirers of Sparta, Socrates.

Socrates: But there is something else that I do not just hear but know full well, and so do you: that Pericles was well regarded at first, and the Athenians levelled no charge of baseness against him when they were in a worse state. However, once they had become good and noble through his agency, towards the end of Pericles' life, they charged him with embezzlement, and indeed almost condemned him to death on the obvious ground that he was corrupt.

516a

Callicles: What of it? Does it follow that Pericles was a bad person?

Socrates: Yet it seems that someone who cares for donkeys or horses or oxen would be bad if he were the sort of person who took charge of them when they neither trampled him nor gored him nor bit him, and turned them out so wild that they performed all these mischiefs. Or do you not think that any caretaker of any living creature whatsoever is bad who takes charge of them when gentle and turns them out wilder than when he took them on? Do you think this or not?

516b

Callicles: Entirely so, just to gratify you.

Socrates: Then you should also gratify me by answering this question. Is a human being also one of those living creatures, or is he not?

Callicles: How could he not be?

Socrates: And did Pericles not care for human beings?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: What now? Should they not have become more just rather than more unjust through his agency, based on what we have agreed a moment ago, if he really took charge of them as a man who was good in relation to civic affairs?

516c

Callicles: Entirely so.

Socrates: Are not just people civilised, according to Homer?⁴¹ But what do you say? Is this not the case?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: And yet, Pericles rendered them more uncivilised than when he took charge of them, and these mischiefs were directed against himself, the last person he would have wanted it for.

Callicles: Do you want me to agree with you?

Socrates: If you think I am speaking the truth.

Callicles: Well, let it be so.

Socrates: Now, since they were more uncivilised, were they not more unjust and bad?

Callicles: Be it so.

Socrates: So, according to this argument, Pericles was not good at civic affairs.

516d

Callicles: You say he was not anyway.

Socrates: By Zeus, even you said so, based on what you have agreed. But tell me again about Cimon. Did not the very people he was caring for ostracise him so that they would not hear his voice for ten years? And did they not do the same things to Themistocles, and punish him with exile too? And they voted to

cast Miltiades, the hero of Marathon, into the pit, and were it not for the presiding official he would have been thrown in. However, if these fellows were good men, as you claim, they would never have suffered those misfortunes. It is not the fate of good charioteers that at the beginning of their careers they are not prone to fall out of the chariots, but when they have tended their horses and have themselves become better charioteers, they are prone to fall out then. This is not the case, either in charioteering or in any other activity. Or do you think it is?

516e

Callicles: I do not.

517a

Socrates: So, it seems that our previous statements were true. We know not a single man in this city who has become good in relation to civic affairs. You agree that there are none among the present generation, and although you selected those four men from the previous generation, they actually turned out to be on a par with the moderns. And so, if they were rhetoricians, they did not employ the true rhetoric, or they would not have been cast out, nor did they use the flattering kind either.

517b

Callicles: But surely, Socrates, none of today's men will ever accomplish anything like what was accomplished by anyone of those four you care to choose.

Socrates: You extraordinary man! I am not criticising these fellows either, not as servants of the city anyway. No, they seem to me to have been of greater service than our contemporaries, and better able to provide the city with what it desired. However, when it came to redirecting those desires rather than pandering to them, persuading and compelling them to the one whereby the citizens were going to be better, in this respect these men of the past were, in a way, no

different from those of the present day. Yet this is the sole task of a good citizen. But I agree with you, that in providing ships, walls and dockyards, and anything else like that, those men were more ingenious than these contemporaries of ours.

Now, you and I are engaging in comical behaviour in these arguments. For throughout our entire discussion we are being borne around unceasingly to the same place, each ignorant of what the other is saying. So, I believe you have agreed many times, and realised that this activity itself is something twofold, both in relation to the body and in relation to the soul. One aspect affords a service by which it can provide food when our bodies are hungry, drink when they are thirsty, clothing, bedding and shoes when they are cold, or whatever else the bodies come to desire. And I am deliberately describing this to you based on the same illustrations so that you may understand more easily. Now, if someone can provide these either as a retailer, a merchant or as a manufacturer of any of these things themselves, being a baker or a cook or weaver or cobbler or tanner, it is little wonder that such a person seems, both to himself and others, to be an attendant of the body. Thus does it seem, to everyone who does not know, that besides all of these activities, there is a particular skill of gymnastics and medicine, which is the true attendance upon the body, and this indeed deserves to rule over all of those other skills and make use of what they produce, because this skill knows what food and drink is useful or detrimental to the excellence of the body, while all the others are ignorant of this. Accordingly, those other skills are slavish, servile and devoid of freedom in their dealings with the body, while gymnastics and medicine are, in justice, their mistress.

Now, when I say that these same considerations also apply to

the soul, you seem to me to understand, and on occasion you agree, as though you know what I mean. But then you come along a little later, claiming that there have been men in this city who were good and noble citizens. But once I ask you who they were, you offer as exemplars men engaged in civic affairs, just as if I were to ask you about gymnastic affairs and which men had become good at this and are good attendants of our bodies, and you were to inform me, in all seriousness, that Thearion the breadmaker, and Mithaikos who wrote the book on Sicilian cookery, and Sarambos the wine merchant prove themselves wonderful attendants upon our bodies as these fellows provide us with wonderful bread in one case, and with food and wine in the other instances.

Perhaps you might get angry if I were to tell you, “My man, you understand nothing about gymnastics. You tell me of men who are servants and satisfiers of desires, while appreciating nothing good and noble about them, who stuff and fatten people’s bodies in any way they can, destroy the natural flesh of the people too, and are praised for doing so. These people, for their part, through inexperience, do not blame the banqueters for causing the diseases, and the wasting of their very flesh when disease arrives a long time later, brought on by the excess indulged without regard to the rules of health. No, they blame whoever happens to be around at the time, and who offers them any advice, and they would do these men harm if they could. And they praise the previous fellows who are responsible for the problems.” And you are now behaving just like this, Callicles, praising men who have feasted these citizens by feeding them up on whatever they desired. Yes, they say that these men have made this city great. But they are not aware that it is bloated and festering because of those men of old. For, omitting sound-mindedness and justice, they have filled up the city

with harbours and dockyards and walls and tribute-money and nonsense of that sort, yet whenever a bout of debilitation afflicts her, they blame the present-day advisers, and praise Themistocles and Cimon and Pericles, the men who caused the problems. And they will probably attack you if you are not careful, and my own companion Alcibiades⁴² too, whenever they lose what they had to begin with, along with all they have acquired since. Not that you have direct responsibility for the problems, but perhaps you do share some responsibility.

What is more, I also see an absurd process going on these days, and I hear about it too in relation to the men of old. For I observe that whenever the city proceeds against one of its political men on the grounds that he acted unjustly, they get angry and complain bitterly because they are treated so terribly. They argue that having done so much good for the city, they are now being destroyed by it in an unjust manner. But this is a complete lie, for not one protector of a city could ever be destroyed by the very city that he was protecting. Indeed, the circumstances of those who make themselves out to be politicians, and those who set themselves up as sophists, are probably the same. In fact, the sophists, though wise in other respects, engage in this strange process by which, having claimed to be teachers of excellence, they frequently accuse their own pupils of treating them unjustly by withholding payment from them and failing to afford them any gratitude for being so well treated by them. Now, what process could be more irrational than this description by which men, who have become good and just, whose injustice has been eradicated by their teacher, who have come to possess justice, behave unjustly on account of that which they do not possess? Does this not seem strange to you, my friend? In truth, Callicles, you have made it necessary for me

to engage in mob oratory, through your reluctance to answer me.

519d

Callicles: But were you not the one who was unable to speak unless someone responded to you?

Socrates: So it seemed, anyway. But now, since you are unwilling to answer me, I am protracting my utterances quite considerably. But, good man, tell me in the name of friendship, does it not seem irrational to you for someone who claims to have made someone else good to censure that person, because having become good through his agency, and still being good, he is an evildoer after all?

519e

Callicles: It seems so, to me anyway.

Socrates: Do you not hear this sort of thing from those men who claim to educate people towards excellence?

Callicles: I do. But what can you say about people who are worthless?

Socrates: And what can you say about those who, whilst claiming to have taken charge of the city and cared for it, so that it will be as good as it possibly can be, turn around when circumstances dictate, and accuse it of being a gross evil doer? Do you think these fellows differ at all from the others? Sophist and rhetorician are the same, bless you, or nearly so, and very similar, just as I was saying to Polus. But you, through ignorance, think that rhetoric is something glorious, and you despise the other activity. But in truth, to the extent that law-making is more noble than jurisprudence, and gymnastic than medicine, so too is sophistry more noble than rhetoric. And I for one believe that the popular speakers and sophists alone are not permitted to censure the very personage whom they educate, on the grounds that he is corrupt in his dealing

with themselves, or else they would, by this same argument, be accusing themselves of not benefiting those whom they claim to benefit. Is this not so?

520c

Callicles: Entirely so.

Socrates: And if what I said is true, I presume it is acceptable for them alone, so it seems, to bestow this service without a fee. For in the case of some other service, someone who has received the benefit might perhaps withhold the recompense. For instance, someone who has become a fast runner through the agency of a trainer might do so if the trainer were to bestow the service without stipulating a fee and arranging to get the money as soon as the swiftness had been bestowed. Yet it is certainly not on account of slowness, I presume, that people act unjustly, but on account of injustice. Is this so?

520d

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: Therefore, if someone eradicates this injustice itself, he should not fear that any injustice will ever befall him, and this service alone may be bestowed without any risk if anyone is really able to make another person good. Is this not the case?

Callicles: I agree.

Socrates: So, for these reasons, it seems there is no disgrace in taking money for giving advice on other matters, such as house-building or on other areas of expertise.

520e

Callicles: So it seems anyway.

Socrates: And yet, when it comes to advising on how one may be as good as possible and best manage one's own household and city, it is regarded as a disgrace to refuse to give advice on this unless someone gives you money. Is this so?

Callicles: Yes.

Socrates: And the reason for this is, of course, that this is the only service that makes the recipient of the benefit desire to confer a benefit in return. Accordingly, it seems to be a good sign if someone who has conferred a benefit through this service is treated well in return, and it is not a good sign if he is not. Is this how matters stand?

521a

Callicles: It is.

Socrates: Now, define which of these services to the city you are encouraging me to engage in, the one that struggles with the Athenians, like a physician, so that they will become as good as possible, or the one where I serve them and minister to their pleasure? Tell me the truth, Callicles, for it is right that since you were so frank with me in the beginning, you continue to say what you are thinking. So, speak out truly and nobly.

Callicles: Well then, I mean that you should act as their servant.

521b

Socrates: So, noblest of men, you are encouraging me to act as their flatterer.

Callicles: Yes, if it pleases you to be so blunt, Socrates. Since if you do not engage in this...

Socrates: Please do not say what you have said many times, that whoever wishes will kill me so that I, for my part, do not have to say that he will do so as an evil man killing a good man. Nor should you say that he will confiscate all my possessions, so that I, for my part, do not have to say that once he has confiscated them, he will not know how he should use them. Rather, having confiscated them from me in an unjust manner, he will make use of them in the unjust manner in which he acquired them, and if he uses them unjustly he uses them basely, and if he uses them basely he uses them badly.

521c

Callicles: You seem to me, Socrates, to believe that you will not suffer a single one of these misfortunes, as though you dwell apart and could not be hauled into court, probably by some utterly corrupt and quite ordinary person.

Socrates: Well, I am, in truth, a fool, Callicles, if I do not believe that in this city of ours anything can happen to anyone. However, I do know that if I were to end up in court facing one of these dangers you refer to, the one who prosecuted me would be an evil-doer, for no worthy person would take an innocent man to court, and it would be nothing strange if I were put to death. Would you like me to tell you why I expect all this?

521d

Callicles: Entirely so.

Socrates: I believe that I am one of few Athenians – I do not say I am the only one – who has taken to the true skill of civic affairs, and I am the only person these days who engages in civic affairs, since any words I ever speak are spoken not with a view to gratification, but with a view to what is best rather than what is most pleasant. And, having no desire to engage in those subtleties that you recommend, I shall have nothing to say in the courtroom. And the same argument that I presented to Polus applies to me, for I shall be judged as a physician would be judged before a jury of children on the accusations of a cook. Yes, consider this. What defence would a person like this, trapped in these circumstances, make if someone were to accuse him, saying, “O children, this man here has inflicted many evils upon you, yes, on yourselves. And he maims the very youngest of you by cutting and burning, he induces distress by withering and choking you, gives you bitter potions and makes you go hungry and thirsty, unlike me who have feasted you sumptuously on a great variety of pleasant delights.” What do you think a physician caught up in such an evil predicament

would be able to say? And if he were to speak the truth, that “Children, I have carried out all of these procedures for the sake of health”, would there not be an enormous outcry from such jurors as those?

522b

Callicles: Probably. I should think so.

Socrates: Do you not think he would be in utter perplexity as to what he should say?

Callicles: Entirely so.

Socrates: Now, I know that I too would find myself in such a predicament as this were I to be landed in court. Indeed, I would not even be able to recount any pleasures I have provided to them which these people regard as services or benefits, and I would envy neither those who provide them nor the people to whom they are provided. And if someone were to say that I corrupt the young people by reducing them to perplexity, or that I revile the older generation by speaking bitter words to them in public or in private, I would be unable to state the truth that “I say all this and I enact all this in a just manner, O gentlemen of the jury”, to use your phrase, Callicles. And I would have nothing else to say either, and so I would suffer whatever fate might decree.

522c

Callicles: Well, Socrates, do you think a man who is unable to help himself when he is in this situation is well established in the city?

522d

Socrates: Yes, Callicles, if he possessed one quality which you have accepted on a number of occasions: if he has assisted himself not to be unjust, neither towards gods nor men, neither in word nor in deed. For we have agreed many times that this assistance to oneself is the most powerful. So, if someone were

to convict me of being unable to help myself or anyone else through this kind of assistance, I would be ashamed, whether I was convicted by many people, by a few, or one on one. And if I were to be put to death on account of this particular inability, I would be troubled by that. But if I were put to death because I lack the flattering kind of rhetoric, I know very well that you would see me bearing death lightly. For no one is afraid of dying itself, unless he is utterly irrational and cowardly. Rather he is afraid of acting unjustly. For the worst of all calamities is to arrive in Hades with one's soul full of injustices. And if you wish, I am prepared to give you an account indicating that this is the case.

522e

Callicles: Well, since you have concluded the other issues, conclude this too.

523a

Socrates: Then, listen to a very beautiful narrative, as they say, one which I believe you may regard as a myth, but which I regard as an account, for whatever I am about to recount to you I shall recount as the truth. Indeed, as Homer explains, Zeus, Poseidon and Pluto made a distribution of the sovereignty after they inherited it from their father.⁴³ Now, there was a law relating to humanity from the time of Cronus, which had always been in place, and still is among the gods. Those people who have passed their lives in a just and holy manner depart, after they die, to the Isles of the Blest to dwell in complete happiness far from evils, while those who have lived in an unjust and godless manner go to the prison-house of retribution and justice that they call Tartarus. But in the time of Cronus, and even more recently under the sovereignty of Zeus, their judges were alive, and they were judged whilst still alive on the very day they were going to die, and so the cases were judged badly. Then both Pluto and the attendants from the Isles of the Blest went to Zeus and

reported that undeserving people were making their way to them in either place. So Zeus said, "Well, I shall stop this from happening. The cases are indeed being decided badly at present, for those who are judged are judged whilst fully clothed because they are judged whilst still living. So, many people possessing degenerate souls are clothed in beautiful bodies, lineage and wealth, and once there is a trial, numerous witnesses appear on their behalf testifying that they have lived in a just manner. Now, the judges are overwhelmed by all this, and what is more, they themselves are fully clothed as they make their judgements, having concealed their own souls behind eyes and ears and the entire body. All of these, both their own clothing and that of the people being judged, become a screen in front of them. So, in the first place," he said, "their foreknowledge of death must be stopped, for at present they know in advance. And so Prometheus has been instructed to put an end to this foreknowledge of theirs.⁴⁴ Hereafter, they must be judged naked of all those additions, for judgement must be passed when they have died. And their judge must be naked, dead, immediately beholding their soul itself with his soul itself once each person has died, bereft of kindred, having left that entire order behind him on the earth, so that the judgement may be just. Now I, having recognised these issues before you did, have made judges of my own sons, two from Asia, Minos and Rhadamanthus, and one from Europe, Aeacus.⁴⁵ Accordingly, as soon as people die, they will pass judgement in the meadow, at the fork from which two roads lead, one to the Isles of the Blest and the other to Tartarus. Rhadamanthus will judge those from Asia, Aeacus those from Europe, and I shall bestow seniority upon Minos to give a final judgement in case either of the others are in perplexity, so that the decision about the destination of human beings may be as just as possible."

Well, Callicles, this is what I have heard and believe to be true, and on the basis of those accounts I conclude that certain consequences follow. It seems to me that death happens to be nothing else but the separation from one another of two entities, the soul and the body. And yet once they have been separated from one another, both of them retain their own condition, which is no worse than when the man was alive, and so the body retains its own nature, and all the care it was given and all the afflictions it suffered are plain to be seen. For instance, if someone's body was large either by nature or through nurture or both, the corpse of this man will be large once he has died, and if he was fat it will be fat when he is dead, and the same goes for the other characteristics. And what is more, if he had long hair his corpse will be long-haired, and if he was a rogue who merited whipping and he had the scars, the imprints of the blows on his body, either from whips or from other injuries during his life, one can see that the corpse also has these when he is dead. Or if someone's limbs were broken or deformed during his life, those same features will be in evidence when he has died. And, in short, whatever bodily features he developed while he was alive will also be in evidence, all of them or most of them, for some time after he has died.

And so, Callicles, it seems to me that the same argument applies to the soul. Everything in the soul is plain to be seen once it has been stripped of the body, both the natural qualities and the effects that the person retains in his soul due to the conduct of particular actions. Now, when they arrive in front of the judge, those from Asia stand before Rhadamanthus, and Rhadamanthus stops them and beholds the soul of each, not knowing whose soul it is. And very often,

having come across the Great King, or some other king or potentate, he observes that there is nothing healthy in the soul, rather it bears the marks of scourging and is full of scars which his own behaviour has imprinted upon his soul on account of oath breaking and injustices. Its ways are all crooked due to falsity and pretence, and nothing is straight because its nurture was devoid of truth. And he sees the soul full of distortion and deformity due to licence, luxury, insolence and unrestrained actions. Having seen this, he sends it away in dishonour straight to the confine, where on arrival it will await the afflictions that are appropriate to it.

It is proper that all who undergo punishment, and are punished by another in the correct manner, either become better and are benefited, or else act as examples to other people so that others who see them being afflicted by whatever they suffer may become better out of fear. Now, those who are benefited, and make retribution before gods and men, are the people who have engaged in transgressions that are curable. Nevertheless, it is through pain and suffering that the benefit comes to them, both here and in Hades, for they cannot be quit of injustice in any other way. However, those who have engaged in utterly unjust actions and are rendered incurable on account of such injustices are the ones who act as examples to others. These people themselves are no longer benefited at all, since they are incurable. But other people are benefited when they see them suffering the most enormous, most painful and most fearful afflictions throughout eternity on account of their transgressions, simply hanging up as examples there, in Hades, in the prison-house, a spectacle and a warning to those unjust people who are continually arriving there. And if what Polus says is true, then I maintain that Archelaus will be one of these, as will anyone else who is a tyrant of that sort.

And I believe most of these examples to other people have come from the ranks of tyrants, kings, potentates and those who administer the affairs of our cities, for these people, on account of their immense power, also engage in the most enormous and unholy transgressions. Homer bears witness to these claims when he represents kings and potentates as the ones who are punished throughout eternity in Hades – Tantalus and Sisyphus and Tityus.⁴⁶ But no one represents Thersites, or any other wrongdoer who is a private citizen, as being incurable and afflicted by these enormous punishments, for in my view he lacked the immense power and so is more fortunate than those who do possess power. Anyway, Callicles, the people who become extreme evildoers come indeed from the ranks of the powerful, yet there is nothing to prevent good men from arising among them too, and those who do arise deserve great admiration. Indeed, Callicles, it is difficult, and deserving of much praise, to live one's life in a just manner having come by an enormous power to act unjustly. Few people of this sort arise. And yet they have arisen, both here and elsewhere, and in my view there will be more of them, noble and good in this excellence of managing in a just manner whatever is entrusted to them. One even became extremely well respected among the other Greeks as well, Aristides,⁴⁷ son of Lysimachus. But, best of men, most of the powerful people became corrupt.

Now, as I was saying, once the judge Rhadamanthus gets hold of someone like this, he knows nothing else about him at all, neither who he is nor who he is descended from, except that he is an evil doer. And having discerned this, he dispatches him to Tartarus with a mark indicating whether he is regarded as curable or incurable, and when he arrives there he suffers whatever is appropriate. But sometimes when he looks upon another soul that has lived a holy life in company

with truth, belonging to a private citizen or someone else, especially, or so I assert anyway Callicles, the soul of a philosopher who has performed his own duties and has not been excessively active throughout his life, he is delighted and despatches it to the Isles of the Blest. Aeacus also engages in the same activities, both of them holding a staff, but Minos sits and oversees them, he alone holding a sceptre of gold, as Homer's Odysseus says that he saw him

*holding a golden sceptre, passing judgements upon the dead.*⁴⁸

Now then, Callicles, I have been persuaded by these accounts, and I give consideration to how I might present my soul to the judge in the healthiest possible condition. So, having bidden farewell to the honours so prized by humanity, practising the truth, I shall endeavour to live my life being as good as I can actually be, and when I die, to die in the same manner. And to the best of my ability I encourage all other people as well, and indeed I exhort you in return towards this life and this struggle, which I assert exceeds all the struggles of this world. And I censure you, because you will be unable to assist yourself whenever you come to the trial and the judgement I have just described. Rather, having arrived in front of that judge, the son of Aegina, once he has hold of you and is controlling you, you will gape and you will be dizzy in that place, just as much as I am in this place, and someone will probably slap you contemptuously on the face and splatter you all over with mud.

Well then, perhaps these descriptions seem to you just like a myth an old woman might recount, and you despise them. And it would be no surprise if we were to despise them, if, in our search, we were somehow able to discover something better and truer than them. But now you see that the three of

you, yourself, Polus and Gorgias, who really are the wisest Greeks of the present day, are unable to prove that one should live any other life than this one, a life which also turns out to be profitable in the hereafter. But in the midst of all these assertions, the others having been refuted, this proposition alone is left undisturbed: that it is necessary to be more wary of doing injustice than of suffering injustice; and it is all the more important for a man to work at being good, both in private and in public, rather than seeming good; and if he becomes bad in some respect, he should be punished. And this good, becoming good and paying a penalty by being punished, stands in second place after being good. And all flattery concerning yourself or concerning others, be they few or be they many, must be shunned, and rhetoric should be used in this manner, always directed to the just, and so should every other activity.

So heed me, and follow me to a place where, on arrival, you will be happy both in life and after death, as the argument indicates. And let someone despise you as a fool and splatter you with mud if he wants to. Yes, by Zeus, and be bold enough to let him strike you that contemptuous blow, for nothing terrible will befall you if you really are noble and good, practising excellence. And after we have practised together in this way, then at that stage, if we deem it useful, we shall contribute to civic affairs, or we shall deliberate upon whatever issues occur to us as we shall be better equipped to deliberate than we are now. Indeed, it is quite disgraceful, given our present condition, that we disport ourselves in a youthful fashion as if we amounted to something, we who are in such an ill-educated state that we never, ever, hold the same views on the same issues, even on issues of the utmost importance. So, let us use the argument that has now been revealed to us, just like a guide. It has indicated to us that this

way of life is best: to live and to die in the practice of justice and all other excellence. So, let us follow this, and encourage others to do so, and not that way of life that you believe in and encourage upon me, for that is worth nothing, Callicles.

NOTES

1. Gorgias was a noted and influential rhetorician and sophist from Leontini in Sicily.
2. An exhibition was a sample lecture or set speech used to show off the skill of a sophist or professional teacher.
3. Chaerephon was Socrates' close friend who famously asked the oracle at Delphi whether there was anyone wiser than Socrates (Apology 21a). He appears in a number of Plato's dialogues.
4. The commercial and civic centre of Athens, and a gathering place.
5. Callicles is thought to have been an Athenian political thinker, but there is no further evidence for his existence outside of this dialogue.
6. Polus was from Acragas in Sicily. He was an orator and a student of Gorgias. He also appears in Plato's Phaedrus and Theages.
7. Aristophon's brother was Polygnotus, the famous 5th-century mural and vase painter.
8. Iliad vi.211 and xiv.113.
9. Zeuxis was an accomplished painter from Heraclea in the south of modern-day Italy. He was especially known for his facility in reproducing nature.
10. Themistocles and Pericles were important Athenian statesmen. The Themistoclean walls included both city walls and walls around the port of Piraeus. The later Periclean 'Long Walls' linked Athens with her port.
11. The Middle Wall was built in 444-442 to enclose the military road from Athens to the Piraeus, and ran parallel to the north Long Wall.
12. A light-hearted oath alluding to the Egyptian dog-headed god, Anubis.
13. Anaxagoras was a natural philosopher from Clazomenae, Ionia, who lived a generation before Socrates. The opening line of his book, describing the initial state of the universe, was "All things were together."
14. The Great King traditionally referred to the King of the Persian Empire.
15. Socrates mentions three Athenian political leaders – Nicias, an old-fashioned conservative, Aristocrates, an oligarch, and Pericles, a democrat.
16. The Council consisted of 500 citizens from each of the ten tribes, chosen by lot to serve for one year. Its chief function was to prepare legislation for the Assembly.

17. The Athenian citizen body was divided into ten tribes which were united politically, militarily and socially, and represented the three regions of Attica – the coast, the plains and the hills.
18. Each tribe served in rotation on the Executive Committee of the Council. A member was chosen daily by lot to be the president or chairman.
19. Alcibiades was a prominent and controversial Athenian statesman, orator and general. He was a close associate of Socrates, and two dialogues that bear his name have been attributed to Plato. He also features prominently towards the end of Plato's *Symposium*, where he describes his relationship with Socrates.
20. The Athenian *demos* refers to the populace of Athens. *Demos* also happens to be the name of Callicles' beloved.
21. This is a light-hearted euphemistic oath alluding to the dog-headed god, Anubis.
22. Xerxes, the son of Darius, was King of the Persian (Achaemenid) Empire.
23. This fragment is from a lost ode of Pindar.
24. This refers to the Tenth Labour of Heracles. Geryon was a fearsome legendary giant who is described as having had multiple heads and/or bodies.
25. Euripides was one of the three great Athenian tragic playwrights. These lines, from a much-quoted speech by Zethus, appear in his play *Antiope*.
26. *Iliad* ix.441.
27. Amphion is the musician brother of Zethus, who was a herdsman. In *Antiope*, the brothers represent two contrasting ways of life, one artistic, the other practical.
28. Both here and in the lines quoted above, Callicles paraphrases Euripides' *Antiope*.
29. These were wealthy, ambitious and somewhat unscrupulous young men. Teisander was a property owner, Andron an oligarchic politician, and Nausicydes a miller and owner of foreign slaves.
30. These lines are from Euripides' *Phrixus* or *Polyidos*.
31. A catamite was the passive partner in male homosexual relationships.

32. This refers to annual initiation rites. The Lesser Mysteries were held in spring in Attica; the Greater Mysteries were held in autumn at the Sanctuary of Demeter and Kore in Eleusis.
33. Cinesias was a poet who composed choral songs in honour of Dionysus. Meles was a famous cithara player but a very poor singer.
34. Not following Dodds' punctuation, who has this as a question.
35. Epicharmus was a comic poet from Syracuse in Sicily. The source of the line quoted is unknown.
36. Aegina is an island, south of Athens, in the Saronic Gulf.
37. There are six obols in a drachma.
38. The Pontus is the region of northern Asia Minor including the south coast of the Black Sea.
39. There was a widespread belief that Thessalian witches caused eclipses and had to pay for their powers with the loss of a family member.
40. Not accepting Dodds' emendation of the manuscript text at this point.
41. The phrase 'kindly and god-fearing' is used three times in Homer's *Odyssey* vi.120, ix.175, xiii.201.
42. Alcibiades was condemned to death in absentia after he had fled to Sparta.
43. *Iliad* xv.187ff.
44. Prometheus was the champion and benefactor of mankind to whom he gave fire. His name means 'forethought'.
45. Minos, Rhadamanthus and Aeacus were famous judges in their lifetimes who became judges in the underworld after death.
46. The punishments of Tantalus, Sisyphus and Tityus are described in Homer's *Odyssey* xi.576-600.
47. Aristides was an Athenian politician and general. Nicknamed 'the Just', he was a leader of the Athenian resistance against the Persian invasion.
48. *Odyssey* xi.569.

Hippias Major

ΙΠΠΙΑΣ ΜΕΓΑΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES *of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus*

HIPPIAS *of Elis, a polymath, sophist and diplomat*

scene: a public place in Athens

281a

Socrates: Ah, it is the handsome and wise Hippias! It has been quite some time since you last set foot in Athens.

Hippias: I don't have the time, Socrates. For whenever Elis needs any business transacted with any other cities, I am the first citizen it approaches, choosing me as ambassador on the assumption that I am the most competent judge and reporter of the communications from the various cities. Now, although I have acted as ambassador to other cities on many occasions, I have dealt most often on the most frequent and important matters with Sparta. And that's why, to answer your question, I don't visit this part of the world too often.

281b

Socrates: Well, that is what comes of being a truly wise and accomplished man, Hippias. For in the private sphere, you are indeed well able to secure lavish payment from the young people, and the benefit you confer upon them exceeds the amount you are paid. And what is more, in the public sphere you are well able to do good work for your own city, as befits someone who is not going to be despised but held in high regard by most people. But, Hippias, what precisely is the reason why those men of old, whose names are a byword for wisdom – Pittacus and Bias, and the associates of Thales of Miletus and those who came later, down to Anaxagoras – all of them, or most of them, apparently refrained from political activity?

281d

Hippias: Why do you think, Socrates? Weren't they just lacking in ability, and the competence to reach an understanding of

both the public and private spheres?

Socrates: In that case, by Zeus, may we say that just as the other skills have advanced and the ancients are of no account compared with today's craftsmen, your skill too, the skill of the sophists, has also advanced in this way and that the ancients who were concerned with wisdom are of no account compared to you?

Hippias: Yes, very much so, that is correct.

282a

Socrates: So, Hippias, if Bias were to come back to life nowadays, he would be an object of fun, just as statue makers say that Daedalus would be a laughing stock if he had been born in our times and were to produce the sort of works that made his reputation.

Hippias: The situation is just as you describe it, Socrates, yet I make a habit of praising our ancient forbears first and to a greater extent than our contemporaries, for although I am wary of the malice of the living, I am in fear of the wrath of the dead.

282b

Socrates: Hippias, in my view you are using words and formulating your thoughts beautifully. I too can bear witness to the truth of what you are saying, that this skill of yours really has advanced in its ability to conduct civic affairs and private affairs too. For this fellow, Gorgias, the sophist from Leontini, arrived here once on a civic matter, acting as ambassador for his own country because he was the most competent of the Leontinians when it came to public affairs. In the public arena he seemed to speak excellently, and in private by putting on exhibitions and associating with young people, he earned a lot of money and took it out of the city. Or take our own friend, Prodicus, if you like, a man who has come here many times, sometimes on public business. But the last time, when he came

here recently from Ceos on public business and spoke in the Council, he was very highly regarded, and by putting on exhibitions in private and associating with young people he made an astonishing amount of money. But none of those ancients ever thought fit to charge a fee or put on exhibitions of their own wisdom to anyone and everyone. In this respect they were simple-minded, and unaware that money is extremely valuable. But each of these men, and Protagoras before them, made more money from wisdom than any craftsman made out of any skill whatsoever.

282d

Hippias: Well, Socrates, you know nothing about the beauties of this. In fact, you would be amazed if you knew how much money I have made. And leaving aside the other places, I once arrived in Sicily while Protagoras was on a visit there. He was well regarded, an older man, while I much younger, yet in a very short time I made more than one hundred and fifty minae, and in one very small place, Inycum, I made more than twenty minae. And when I got home with this I gave it to my father, and he and the rest of my fellow citizens were amazed and awestruck. And I almost think that I have made more money than any two sophists you would care to name, put together.

283a

Socrates: That is beautiful, Hippias, and strong evidence of your own wisdom and the extent to which men of today are superior to the ancients. Indeed, according to your account, your predecessors, Anaxagoras' associates, were very stupid. For they say that what happened to Anaxagoras is the opposite of what happened to you, for although he inherited a lot of wealth, he neglected it and lost everything, so lacking in intelligence was his practice of wisdom. And they tell other stories like this about other men of old too. Now, I think you are presenting beautiful evidence concerning the wisdom of people today compared to that of our predecessors, and many people share

the view that a wise man should be wise for himself most of all, and he is defined, apparently, as the one who makes the most money. Well, I think that is enough said about this, but please tell me, from which of the cities you visited did you make most money? Or is it obvious that it was from Sparta, the one you visited most often?

283b

Hippias: No, by Zeus, Socrates.

Socrates: What are you saying? Did you make least money there?

Hippias: Well, I made nothing at all, ever.

283c

Socrates: That is a monstrous and amazing statement, Hippias. But tell me this, isn't this wisdom of yours the kind that makes better, more excellent people of those who adhere to it and learn it?

Hippias: Indeed, Socrates, very much so.

283d

Socrates: But although you were able to make the sons of the Inycans better, were you incapable of doing this for the sons of the Spartans?

Hippias: Far from it.

Socrates: Well then, do the Sicilians want to become better, while the Spartans do not?

Hippias: No, Socrates, the Spartans want this too, absolutely.

Socrates: Well then, did they avoid dealing with you because they were short of money?

Hippias: Certainly not. They have enough of that.

Socrates: Then how could it be that although they had the desire and the money, and you were able to confer enormous

benefits upon them, they did not send you on your way loaded with money? Is it that the Spartans could educate their own children better than you could? May we put it like that, and would you agree?

283e

Hippias: No, not at all.

Socrates: Well, was it because you were unable to persuade the young people in Sparta that they would make more progress in excellence by associating with you than they would with their fellow citizens? Or was it because you could not persuade their fathers that they should entrust them to you rather than looking after them themselves, if they really did care for these young people? For I presume they would not begrudge their own children the chance to become as good as they possibly could.

Hippias: No, I don't think they would begrudge them that.

Socrates: And of course, Sparta is well regulated.

Hippias: Of course.

284a

Socrates: And in the well-regulated cities, excellence is held in the highest regard.

Hippias: Entirely so.

Socrates: And you know better than anyone how to impart this to someone else.

Hippias: Yes, very much so, Socrates.

Socrates: Now, wouldn't someone who knows best how to impart the skill of horsemanship be more highly regarded in Thessaly than anywhere else in Greece, and make most money there, and anywhere else that horsemanship is taken seriously?

Hippias: Quite likely.

284b

Socrates: Then wouldn't someone who is able to impart learning, which is of the utmost value in developing excellence, be most highly regarded in Sparta and make most money there if he wanted to, and in any other Greek city that is well regulated? Or do you think, my friend, that he would make more in Sicily and in Inycus? Should we believe that, Hippias? For we must believe it if you tell us to.

Hippias: Socrates, it is against ancestral tradition for the Spartans to change their laws, or to educate their sons contrary to their customs.

284c

Socrates: What are you saying? Is acting aright and not falling into error against their ancestral tradition?

Hippias: I wouldn't say so, Socrates.

Socrates: Wouldn't they be acting aright by giving their young folk a better education rather than a worse?

Hippias: They would, but it is not lawful for them to give the young a foreign education, and yet I know very well that if anyone had ever actually been paid for providing education there, I would have been paid by far the most, for they are delighted to hear me and they are full of praise. But, as I say, it is against the law.

284d

Socrates: And are you saying that law is harmful to the city, or a benefit?

Hippias: In my view, it is instituted with benefit in mind, but it sometimes does harm if the law has been badly instituted.

284e

Socrates: What about this? Don't those who institute the law, institute it as something enormously good for the city? And without this, isn't it impossible to live in a well-regulated

manner?

Hippias: That's true.

Socrates: So, whenever those who set about instituting laws are in error about what is good, they are in error about the law and what is lawful. What do you say?

Hippias: Strictly speaking, Socrates, this is the case, but people are not accustomed to using words with such precision.

Socrates: Are you referring to people who know or people who do not know, Hippias?

Hippias: The majority.

Socrates: And are those who know the truth, the majority?

Hippias: Of course not.

Socrates: And yet, I presume that those who know believe that, in truth, what is more beneficial is more lawful than what is less beneficial to every man. Or do you not agree?

Hippias: Yes, I agree. That's the situation, in truth.

285a

Socrates: Therefore, it is as those who know think it is.

Hippias: Entirely so.

Socrates: And yet, according to you, it is more beneficial for the Spartans to be educated by the education you offer, even though it is foreign, rather than the local education.

Hippias: And what I say is true.

Socrates: Yes, and don't you also say that what is more beneficial is more lawful, Hippias?

Hippias: Yes, I said that.

Socrates: So, according to your account, it is more lawful for the sons of the Spartans to be educated by Hippias and less

lawful for them to be educated by their fathers, if, in fact, they really will be benefited to a greater extent by you.

Hippias: And benefited they will be, Socrates.

285b

Socrates: So the Spartans are acting unlawfully by not giving you money and entrusting their own sons to you.

Hippias: I agree with this, for you seem to be presenting the argument in my favour, and I should say nothing to oppose it.

Socrates: Then we are discovering, my friend, that the Spartans, who are regarded as the most lawful people, are law breakers in matters of the utmost importance. Well, Hippias, by the gods, they praise you and they take delight in hearing what? Or is it obvious that it is the subjects you know best, those concerned with the stars and heavenly phenomena?

Hippias: Not in the least. They cannot stand those subjects.

285c

Socrates: Well, do they enjoy hearing something about geometry?

Hippias: Not at all, since many of them barely know how to count.

Socrates: In that case, they are a long way from putting up with one of your exhibitions of calculation.

Hippias: A long way indeed, by Zeus.

Socrates: Well then, is it those subjects where you know how to make more precise distinctions than anyone concerning the effect of letters and syllables, rhythm and harmony?

Hippias: My good man! Harmonies and letters indeed!

285d

Socrates: Then what do they listen to with such delight, and what do they praise you for? Tell me yourself since I cannot

work it out.

Hippias: They love to hear about genealogies of heroes and humans, Socrates, and the settlements that established their cities in times gone by and, in short, all the ancient lore. So I have been forced to learn everything of this sort by heart and practise it thoroughly because of them.

285e

Socrates: By Zeus, Hippias, you are lucky the Spartans do not delight in having someone recite the list of our Archons, beginning with Solon, or else you would have had quite a job memorising them.

Hippias: Why so, Socrates? I can remember fifty names having heard them just once.

286a

Socrates: That is true, yes, I forgot that you have this gift of memory. I now realise that the Spartans are delighted with you because you know a lot, and they use you, as children use old women, to tell stories in a pleasant manner.

Hippias: Yes, by Zeus, about beautiful activities, too, and just recently I was very popular there for recounting the activities a young person should pursue. For I have a most beautiful speech that I composed on this topic, generally well structured, especially in its language. And I have a device and a starting point for the speech as follows. After Troy had fallen, the speech recounts that Neoptolemus asked Nestor what sort of activities are beautiful, the sort that would make a young person really famous. After this I have Nestor speaking, proposing all sorts of regulations to him, most beautiful. Now, I delivered this in Sparta and I shall also deliver it here the day after tomorrow in the schoolroom of Pheidostratus, along with much else that is also worth hearing. Indeed Eudicus, the son of Apemantus, invited me. But you should be there too, and bring other people

as well who are up to the task of evaluating what they have heard.

286c

Socrates: Well, that is what will happen, Hippias, God willing. But, for now, answer a short question about the speech for me, since you have given me a timely reminder about beauty. In fact, just recently, good man, someone cast me into perplexity when I was criticising parts of some speeches as base and praising others as beautiful. He questioned me in a most insolent manner, somewhat as follows, “How do you know, Socrates, the sort of things that are beautiful or base? Well, come on, would you be able to say what the beautiful is?” And because of my inadequacy I was perplexed and was unable to answer him in the right way. So as I went away, I was angry with myself, and I blamed myself, and I resolved that the next time I came across one of you men of wisdom, I would listen, learn and practise, and then go back to my questioner again and contest the point once more. So now, as I say, your arrival is timely, and so give me adequate instruction as to what the beautiful itself is, and as you reply, try to speak as precisely as possible, in case I get refuted a second time and become a laughing stock all over again. For you surely know all too well, and since your knowledge is so extensive, this would presumably be a trivial matter.

Hippias: A trivial matter, indeed, Socrates, and in a sense, by Zeus, of no significance.

Socrates: Then, I will learn it easily and no one will refute me again.

287a

Hippias: No one, indeed, or else my profession would prove to be inadequate and ordinary.

Socrates: By Hera, what you are saying is all very well, Hippias, provided we get the better of the man. But what is to stop me imitating the fellow when you respond, by challenging your arguments so that you give me as much practice as possible? Indeed, I am somewhat experienced in putting up challenges. So if it makes no difference to you, I would like to put up challenges so that I may learn in a more robust manner.

287b

Hippias: Yes, please challenge me. In fact, as I said just now, this is not a major question. No, I could teach you to answer much more difficult questions than this, so that no one would be able to refute you.

Socrates: Now, that is good news. But come on, and since you are telling me to do so, let me do my best to become this fellow and attempt to question you. For if you were to present the speech you mentioned to him, the one about beautiful activities, he would listen, and once you stopped speaking he would first ask you about justice and nothing else. Yes, that is a habit of his, and he would say, “Stranger from Elis, isn’t it by justice that whatever is just, is just?” Well, Hippias, answer as if he was asking you.

287d

Hippias: I shall answer that it is by justice.

Socrates: “In that case, isn’t this justice, something?”

Hippias: Very much so.

Socrates: “And isn’t it by wisdom that anyone wise is wise, and by the good that everything good is good?”

Hippias: How could they not be?

Socrates: “By their being something, and surely not by their not being?”

Hippias: By their being something.

Socrates: “Now, isn’t everything that is beautiful, beautiful by the beautiful?”

Hippias: Yes, by the beautiful.

Socrates: “By this ‘something that is’?”

Hippias: By something that is, what else?

287e

Socrates: “Then tell me, stranger,” he will say, “what is this, ‘the beautiful’?”

Hippias: Socrates, doesn’t someone who asks this question just want to find out what is beautiful?

Socrates: No, Hippias, I think he wants to find out what the beautiful is?

Hippias: And what is the difference between them?

Socrates: Do you think there is none?

Hippias: Yes, there is no difference.

Socrates: But of course you know better. Nevertheless, please consider this, good man, for he is not asking you what is beautiful, but what the beautiful is.

Hippias: I understand, good man, and I shall answer and tell him what the beautiful is, and I shall never be refuted. Indeed, Socrates, mark my words, if the truth must be spoken, a beautiful girl is beautiful.

288a

Socrates: Well, Hippias, by the dog, you have answered beautifully at any rate, and remarkably too. So, is it the case that if I give this answer I shall have answered the question I was asked, in a correct manner, and I shall never be refuted?

Hippias: Indeed, how could you be refuted when you are saying what everyone thinks, and when anyone who hears you will

bear witness to its correctness?

Socrates: So be it, very much so. Come on then, Hippias, let me go over what you are saying for myself. He will question me somewhat as follows, “All these things you declare to be beautiful would be beautiful if the beautiful itself is what?” And shall I then say that if a beautiful girl is beautiful, these would be beautiful because of that?

288b

Hippias: Now, do you think he will still attempt to refute you on the grounds that what you are saying is not beautiful, and if he does make the attempt, won’t he become a laughing stock?

Socrates: You marvel, I know very well that he will make the attempt, but whether he will also be a laughing stock if he does so remains to be seen. However, I would like to tell you what he will say.

Hippias: Speak on.

Socrates: “How sweet you are, Socrates!” he will say. “But is a beautiful mare, which even the god praises in his oracle, not beautiful?” What shall we say, Hippias? What else can we say except that the mare, the beautiful one, at any rate, is beautiful? For how could we dare to deny that something beautiful is beautiful?

288c

Hippias: What you are saying is true, Socrates, and the god was right to say so too, for extremely beautiful mares are bred in our land.

288d

Socrates: “So be it,” he will say. “But what of a beautiful lyre? Is it not beautiful?” Shouldn’t we say it so, Hippias?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: Well, after that I am fairly sure, judging by his manner, that he will say, “Best of men, what about a beautiful pot? Is it not beautiful?”

Hippias: Socrates, who is the man? What an ill-educated person to dare to speak in such commonplace terms on such a serious matter.

Socrates: That is what he is like, Hippias, not refined but common, thinking about nothing else except the truth. But the man must be answered, nevertheless, and I am giving my response first. If the pot has indeed been produced by a good potter, smooth, round and beautifully fired, like some of those two-handled pots that hold six choes, and extremely beautiful, if he were asking about a pot like this, we would have to agree it is beautiful. For how could we say that it is not beautiful, when it is beautiful?

288e

Hippias: We simply could not, Socrates.

Socrates: “In that case,” he will say, “isn’t a beautiful pot, beautiful too? Answer me.”

Hippias: Yes, Socrates, this is the case, I think. This utensil too is beautiful once it has been beautifully wrought, but on the whole, it does not deserve to be judged as beautiful in comparison with a horse, a girl, or all the other beauties.

289a

Socrates: Very well, Hippias, I understand that we should respond to the person who asks these questions as follows, “My man, you are ignoring the fact that Heraclitus¹¹ has a point when he says, ‘The most beautiful monkey is ugly when compared to the class of humans’, and that, according to the wise Hippias, the most beautiful pot is also ugly when compared to the class of girls.” Isn’t this the case, Hippias?

Hippias: Very much so, Socrates, you are responding correctly.

289b

Socrates: Then listen, for I know quite well what he will say after that. “Socrates, what if someone were to compare the girls as a class with that of gods? Won’t the outcome be the same as comparing the class of pots with that of girls? Won’t the most beautiful girl appear ugly? Or doesn’t Heraclitus, whom you quote, also say just this, ‘The wisest of men, when compared to a god, will look like a monkey in wisdom, beauty and every other respect?’” Shall we agree, Hippias, that the most beautiful girl is ugly when compared to the race of gods?

Hippias: Who could possibly contradict this, Socrates?

289c

Socrates: Well then, once we agree with all this he will laugh and say, “Socrates, do you remember what you were asked?” I will reply that I was asked what exactly the beautiful itself is. “In that case,” he will say, “having been asked for the beautiful, are you responding with what happens to be, on your own admission, no more beautiful than ugly?” So it seems, I shall say, or what would you advise me to say, my friend?

Hippias: That’s it. Yes, it is true indeed that the human race is not beautiful when compared to gods.

289d

Socrates: “Now, if I had asked you,” he will say, “at the outset, what is both beautiful and ugly, and you had answered as you did just now, you would have answered correctly, wouldn’t you? But do you still think that the beautiful itself, by which everything else is embellished and appears beautiful when this form is added, is a girl or a horse or a lyre?”

Hippias: Well then, Socrates, if that is what he is looking for, it is the easiest question in the world to answer and state what the beautiful is, by which everything is indeed embellished and appears beautiful once this is added. Yes, the fellow is simple-minded and understands nothing about beautiful

possessions. For if you were to respond that what he is asking for, the beautiful, is none other than gold, he would be blocked and would not attempt to refute you. For presumably we all know that whatever this is added to, even if it previously looked ugly, looks beautiful once it has been embellished with gold.

290a

Socrates: Hippias, you have no experience of how relentless the man is; he accepts nothing easily.

Hippias: What does that matter, Socrates? For he needs to accept whatever has been stated correctly, or else become a laughing stock for not accepting it.

Socrates: Well, not only will he not accept this answer, best of men, but he will mock me, hugely, and will say, “Oh you mad person, do you think Pheidias¹³ is a bad craftsman?” And I shall reply, I think, “No, not at all.”

Hippias: And you will be right to say so, Socrates.

290b

Socrates: Right, indeed. And so, once I agree that Pheidias is a good craftsman, he will say, “Do you think Pheidias was ignorant of this ‘beautiful’ you are speaking of?” And I shall reply, “Why do you ask?” And he will say, “Because he did not make the eyes of Athena from gold, nor her hands, but from ivory, even though they would have looked most beautiful if made of gold. Obviously he made this mistake through ignorance, being ignorant of the fact that gold is what makes everything to which it is added, beautiful.” How should we respond to him when he says this, Hippias?

Hippias: That’s not difficult. We shall say that he made the statue properly since ivory, I think, is beautiful too.

290c

Socrates: “In that case,” he will say, “why did he not also make the centre of the eyes from ivory rather than stone, finding

stone that was very like ivory? Or is a beautiful stone also beautiful?" Shall we say so, Hippias?

Hippias: Yes, we shall say so, whenever it is appropriate.

Socrates: "And whenever it is not appropriate, is it ugly?" Should I agree, or not?

Hippias: Yes, agree, whenever it is not appropriate, at any rate.

290d

Socrates: "Then, what about the ivory and the gold, oh wise one?" he shall say. "Don't they make things look beautiful when they are appropriate, and ugly when they are not?" Shall we deny this or agree that what he is saying is right?

Hippias: We will agree with that anyway. Whatever is appropriate to each is what makes each beautiful.

Socrates: He will say, "Whenever someone is boiling the pot we mentioned earlier, the beautiful one, full of beautiful soup, is a gold ladle appropriate to it or a fig wood ladle?"

290e

Hippias: By Heracles, what sort of man is this, Socrates? Don't you want to tell me who he is?

Socrates: If I were to tell you his name, you would not recognise it.

Hippias: But I do recognise, even now, that he is a fool.

Socrates: He is a thoroughgoing pestilence, Hippias, but, nevertheless, what shall we say? Which of the two ladles is appropriate to the soup and to the pot? Or is it obviously the one made from fig wood? For it is likely to make the soup smell nicer, and at the same time, my friend, it would not shatter our pot, spill the soup, put out the fire, and deprive the impending diners of their noble meal, while the golden one would do all that. And so I think we should say that the fig wood is more

appropriate than the golden unless you have an alternative suggestion.

291a

Hippias: No, it is more appropriate, Socrates. However, I would not engage in discourse with a person who asks questions of that kind.

291b

Socrates: And rightly so, my friend. Yes, it would not be appropriate for you to adopt this sort of language when you are so beautifully dressed, so beautifully shod, and so famous for your wisdom among all the Greeks. But it is not a problem for me to consort with this person, so give me some preparatory instructions. Answer the question for my sake. The man will ask, “Well, if the fig wood is indeed more appropriate than the golden, wouldn’t it also be more beautiful, since you have actually agreed, Socrates, that what is appropriate is more beautiful than what is not appropriate?” Can we help but agree, Hippias, that the fig wood ladle is more beautiful than the golden one?

Hippias: Socrates, would you like me to suggest what you should say the beautiful is, if you want to save yourself a lot of argumentation?

291c

Socrates: Very much so, but not before you first tell me how I should answer the question, which of the two ladles I just spoke of is appropriate and also more beautiful?

Hippias: Well tell him, if you like, that it is the one made from fig wood.

Socrates: Then say what you were going to say a moment ago. For by this answer, if I say that the beautiful is gold, it seems to me that gold will turn out to be no more beautiful than fig wood. So what do you now say the beautiful is?

291d

Hippias: I'll tell you, for I think you are seeking a response according to which the beautiful is the sort of thing that will never appear base anywhere, to anyone.

Socrates: Very much so, Hippias, you are now understanding this beautifully.

Hippias: Then listen, and be assured that if anyone has anything to say in opposition to this, you may proclaim that I know nothing at all.

Socrates: By the gods, please tell me as quickly as you can.

Hippias: Well, I say it is always most beautiful for any man, anywhere, to be wealthy, healthy, honoured by his fellow Greeks, to live to old age, to commemorate his own parents beautifully when they die, and be given a beautiful and most appropriate funeral by his own children.

291e

Socrates: My, my, Hippias, you really have spoken wonderfully, magnificently, and in a manner worthy of yourself. And, by Hera, I am delighted at the kind manner in which you seem, to the best of your ability, to be coming to my aid. And yet, we are making no impression on the man. No, he will laugh at us now to an even greater extent, mark my words.

292a

Hippias: The laughter is no good, Socrates. For whenever he has nothing to say on these issues and he laughs, he will be laughing at himself, and he himself will be laughed at by the people around him.

Socrates: Perhaps that is so, and perhaps, if I give this answer, there is a danger, I prophesy, that he will do more than just laugh at me.

Hippias: What do you mean?

Socrates: That if he happens to have a stick, and I don't get away and escape him, he will try to beat me well and truly.

292b

Hippias: What are you saying? Is the man in some sense your owner, and if he does this will he not be charged and pay a penalty? Or is your city lacking in justice, and does it allow the citizens to beat one another unjustly?

Socrates: No, we do not allow that at all.

Hippias: Then he will pay a penalty for striking you unjustly.

Socrates: No, I do not think so, Hippias, not if I were to give him that reply. I think he would be acting justly.

Hippias: Then, I think so too since that is what you yourself believe.

Socrates: Shouldn't I also tell you why I believe he would be acting justly if he beat me for giving that reply? Or will you also beat me without trial? Or will you hear my argument?

292c

Hippias: If I were not to hear you out, it would be a scandal, but what are you saying?

Socrates: I will tell you, imitating that man in the same way I did just now so that I do not speak to you the sort of harsh, uncouth words he speaks to me. For rest assured, he will say, "Tell me, Socrates, would you think it unjust that someone should get beaten for singing a dithyramb of such length, in such an unmusical manner, and so far removed from the question that was asked?" "How so?" I shall ask. "How so?" he will say. "Can't you recall that you were asked for the beautiful itself, by which anything to which it is added turns out to be beautiful, be it a stone, wood, a person or a god, or any action or any subject? For I am asking you, my man, what beauty itself is, and I am no more able to make you hear me than if you were a

stone seated beside me, a millstone at that, possessing neither ears nor a brain.” Now, Hippias, wouldn’t you be annoyed if, out of fear, I were to reply to this as follows, “But Hippias said this was the beautiful, even though I asked him in the same way you asked me, what is it that is beautiful to everyone, always?” What do you say, wouldn’t you be annoyed if I were to say this?

292e

Hippias: Well, Socrates, I know quite well that what is beautiful to everyone is what I said it was, and it will seem so to everyone.

Socrates: “And it will be so?” he will say, “for the beautiful is, presumably, always beautiful.”

Hippias: Certainly.

Socrates: “And it was so too, was it?” he will say.

Hippias: It was so too.

Socrates: “So,” he will say, “did the visitor from Elis say that it was beautiful for Achilles to be buried after his parents, and for his grandfather Aeacus, and for all the other offspring of the gods, and for the gods themselves?”

293a

Hippias: What’s this? Away, by heaven! The questions the man is asking are impious, Socrates.

Socrates: What about this? When someone else asks the question, is it entirely impious to say that these things are so?

Hippias: Perhaps not.

Socrates: “Then perhaps you are the person,” he will say, “who declares that it is beautiful for everyone, always, to be buried by their children and to bury their parents. Or was Heracles not included among ‘everyone’, along with all the others we mentioned just now?”

293b

Hippias: But I did not mean that this applies to the gods.

Socrates: “Nor to the heroes either, it seems.”

Hippias: Not those who were children of gods, at any rate.

Socrates: “Only those who were not?”

Hippias: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: “In that case, according to your further account, apparently it is terrible, unholy and a disgrace for the heroes Tantalus, Dardanus and Zethus, but beautiful for Pelops and the others of like parentage.”

Hippias: Yes, I think so.

293c

Socrates: “Then, you are thinking something you did not state earlier,” he will say, “that burying their parents, and being buried by their children, is sometimes, and for some people, a disgrace. More to the point, it is impossible, it seems, for this to become beautiful and to be so for everyone. And so in this case, as with the previous cases, the girl and the pot, the outcome is the same and, even more comically, it is beautiful for some and not beautiful for others. And so far, today,” he will say, “you are still not able to answer the question you are being asked, Socrates, about the beautiful. What is it?”

293d

Socrates: With these words and their like, he will censure me, justifiably, if I reply to him in this manner. Now, Hippias, for the most part he engages me in discourse that proceeds largely in this way. But sometimes, as though he had taken pity on my inexperience and ill-education, he himself offers me a suggestion by asking if such and such is the beautiful or anything else he happens to be enquiring into and discussing.

Hippias: What do you mean by this, Socrates?

293e

Socrates: I will tell you. “Dearest Socrates,” he says, “stop giving answers like that, in that way, for they are too facile and easy to refute. No, consider whether the following seems beautiful to you, something we picked up just now when we said that gold is beautiful for anything to which it is appropriate, and not beautiful for anything to which it is not appropriate, and that the same goes for anything else to which this is added. Take this ‘appropriate’ itself, and the nature of the appropriate itself, and consider whether this happens to be the beautiful.” Now, I usually agree with such suggestions every time, for I do not know what to say, but do you think the appropriate is beautiful?

Hippias: Of course, entirely so, Socrates.

Socrates: Let us consider this in case we are being deceived.

Hippias: Yes, we should consider it.

294a

Socrates: Then look, do we say the appropriate is that which, when it is added, makes anything in which it is present, appear beautiful, or be beautiful, or neither of these?

Hippias: I think it is what makes it appear beautiful. For instance, when someone puts on clothes or shoes that suit him, even if he is odd, he appears more beautiful.

294b

Socrates: Then, if the appropriate does indeed make him appear more beautiful than he is, it would be some deception about the beautiful and would not be what we are looking for, Hippias, would it? For I presume we are looking for that by which all beautiful things are beautiful, just as that by which all large things are large is by excess. For all large things are large by this, and even if they do not appear large, it is necessary that they be large if they exceed. So, in this way, we also say that the beautiful is that by which all things are beautiful, whether they

appear to be so or not. What could it be? Indeed, it could not be the appropriate, for it makes something appear more beautiful than it is, according to your statement, but does not allow them to appear as they are. But try to say what it is that makes them be beautiful, as I said just now, whether they appear so or not, for if we are really seeking the beautiful, this is what we are seeking.

294c

Hippias: But, Socrates, the appropriate makes things be beautiful and appear beautiful, once it is present.

Socrates: Is it impossible for things that are actually beautiful not to appear to be beautiful, once, at any rate, that which makes them appear so is present?

Hippias: Impossible.

294d

Socrates: So, shall we agree on this, Hippias, that everything that is actually beautiful, including regulations and activities, are also thought to be beautiful, and always appear so to everyone? Or is it the complete opposite? Are people in ignorance, and so there is more strife and contention among individuals in private, and between cities in public, over these matters than over anything else?

Hippias: It is much more the latter, Socrates. They are in ignorance.

294e

Socrates: But this presumably would not be so if the ‘appearing’ was added to them. And it would have been added if the appropriate was indeed beautiful, and not only made things be beautiful, but also made them appear so. So, if the appropriate is that which makes things be beautiful, then it would be the beautiful, the object of our search, rather than that which makes them appear beautiful. And what is more, if that which

makes them appear so is the appropriate, it would not be the beautiful, the object of our search. For that makes them be so, but the same thing could not possibly make them appear beautiful and be beautiful, or anything else whatsoever. So, let us decide whether we think the appropriate is what makes things be beautiful or makes them appear so.

Hippias: It makes them appear so, or so it seems to me anyway, Socrates.

295a

Socrates: Alas, Hippias, since the appropriate has proven to be something other than beautiful, the knowledge of what precisely the beautiful is has departed and escaped us.

Hippias: Yes, by Zeus, and in my view, very strangely.

Socrates: However, my friend, we should not let it go just yet, for I still retain a hope that what precisely the beautiful is, will be revealed.

Hippias: Entirely so, Socrates, for it is not difficult to find. So I know quite well that if I were alone for a while and were to consider this for myself, I could express it to you with the utmost accuracy.

295b

Socrates: Ah, Hippias, do not be boastful. You see how much trouble it has brought us already. Take care that it does not get angry and run away all the more. But I am talking nonsense, for you will easily find it I think, once you are on your own. But, by the gods, you should seek it out in my presence and, if you like, search for it along with me as you were doing just now. And if we find it, that will be a most beautiful achievement, and if we do not, I shall accept my fate and you will discover it easily once you depart. And if we find it now, I certainly will not be a nuisance to you hereafter by enquiring as to what you found out when you were by yourself. But take a look now at what you

think the beautiful is. Well, I am saying – and by the way, you should keep a close attentive eye on me in case I am talking nonsense – well then, for us, let whatever is useful be beautiful. And what I had in mind when I said this was as follows, we say that the eyes are beautiful, not the kind that seem to be so but are unable to see, but those that are able to see and are useful for seeing. Is this so?

295c

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: And don't we also say that the whole body is beautiful in some way, in one case for running, in another for wrestling? Doesn't the same apply to all beautiful animals, a horse, a cock or a quail, all equipment, and means of land transport, and ships and triremes on the sea, all instruments used for music or in other skills, all activities and laws too? Are not almost all of these referred to as beautiful in the same way? Looking at each of them, the way each is by nature, the way it has been fashioned, the condition it is in, don't we declare that what is useful is beautiful, in the way that it is useful, for the purpose for which it is useful and at the time it is useful, and whatever is useless in any of these ways is base? So is that what you think too, Hippias?

295d

Hippias: I do.

Socrates: So, are we now right to say that, more than anything else, the useful happens to be beautiful?

Hippias: We are right indeed, Socrates.

Socrates: Now, is that which is capable of accomplishing something useful for the purpose for which it is capable, and is that which is incapable, useless?

Hippias: Certainly.

Socrates: So, capability is beautiful and incapability is base?

295e

Hippias: Emphatically so. Indeed, we have a lot of evidence that this is the case, Socrates, particularly from the political realm. For in political affairs, and in one's own city, being capable is the most beautiful thing of all, and being incapable is the most base of all.

296a

Socrates: That is good. Well now, by the gods, Hippias, on this basis, is wisdom also the most beautiful of all and is ignorance the most base of all?

296b

Hippias: What do you think, Socrates?

Socrates: Let's be careful, my friend, as I am cautious as to what precisely we are now saying.

Hippias: What is there to be afraid of, Socrates, when the argument has proceeded so beautifully this time?

Socrates: I wish it had. But please consider this along with me, could anyone do something that he neither knew how to do, nor was at all capable of doing?

Hippias: Not at all. How could he do what he is not capable of?

Socrates: Now, those who make mistakes and do bad work, and do so unintentionally, if they were incapable of doing what they did, they could never have done it, could they?

Hippias: Obviously.

296c

Socrates: And yet, it is by capability that the capable are capable, for it is surely not by incapability.

Hippias: Of course not.

Socrates: And are all those who do anything, capable of doing what they do?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: But all men do much more bad than good, beginning in childhood, and they make mistakes unintentionally.

Hippias: This is the case.

296d

Socrates: What about this capability, and these things that are useful, but are useful for accomplishing something bad, shall we declare that these are beautiful, or do they fall far short?

Hippias: I think they fall far short, Socrates.

Socrates: In that case, Hippias, for us it seems that the capable and the useful are not the beautiful.

Hippias: They would be, Socrates, if they were capable of doing good and were useful for such purposes.

296e

Socrates: Then, the proposition that the capable and the useful are beautiful without qualification is gone. Rather, what our soul wanted to say was that the capable, and the useful for doing something good, is the beautiful. Was that it?

Hippias: I think so.

Socrates: But surely this is beneficial, isn't it?

Hippias: Entirely so.

Socrates: And so the beautiful bodies, the beautiful regulations, the wisdom and whatever else we just mentioned, are all beautiful because they are beneficial.

Hippias: Obviously.

Socrates: So, the beneficial seems to us to be the beautiful, Hippias.

Hippias: Entirely so, Socrates.

Socrates: But the beneficial is that which does good.

Hippias: It is indeed.

Socrates: And that which does is none other than the cause. Is this so?

Hippias: It is so.

297a

Socrates: So the beautiful is the cause of the good.

Hippias: It is indeed.

Socrates: Now, the cause, and what the cause is the cause of, are different, for presumably the cause would not be a cause of a cause. But consider this, didn't the cause turn out to be doing?

Hippias: Very much so.

Socrates: Now, what is done through the doer is that which arises, and not that which does?

Hippias: This is the case.

Socrates: And that which arises is one thing and that which does is another.

297b

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: So, the cause is not the cause of a cause, but of that which arises because of it.

Hippias: Certainly.

Socrates: So if the beautiful is a cause of the good, the good would arise because of the beautiful. And it seems that is why we are eager for understanding and everything else that is beautiful, because their product, their offspring, the good, is worthy of that eagerness. And from what we are discovering, it

looks as if the beautiful is, in form, a father of the good.

Hippias: Yes, certainly, you are expressing that beautifully, Socrates.

297c

Socrates: Well, is this beautifully expressed too. The father is not son, nor is the son father?

Hippias: Beautifully, indeed.

Socrates: Nor is the cause that which arises, nor, for its part, is that which arises a cause.

Hippias: That is true.

Socrates: By Zeus, best of men, then the beautiful is not good nor is the good beautiful, or do you think this is possible based on what has just been said?

Hippias: No, by Zeus, apparently not.

Socrates: Well, are we satisfied with that; do we wish to state that the beautiful is not good, nor the good beautiful?

Hippias: No, by Zeus, I am not at all satisfied.

297d

Socrates: Indeed, by Zeus, Hippias, for me this is the least satisfactory argument of all those we have formulated so far.

Hippias: So it seems, indeed.

Socrates: Then, it looks to us as if the argument, that the beneficial and that which is useful and capable of making something good is beautiful, is not the most beautiful argument, although it appeared so a moment ago. No, this is not the case. It is even more ridiculous, if that is possible, than those initial arguments in which we thought that the girl was the beautiful, and each one of those we mentioned earlier.

Hippias: So it seems.

297e

Socrates: And I no longer know where I should turn, Hippias; I am perplexed. Do you have anything to say?

Hippias: Not at the moment, but as I said earlier, once I have considered this, I know quite well that I shall make the discovery.

Socrates: But if you put this off, I do not think I can wait for you, I am so eager to know. And in fact, I think I have actually found a way now. Yes, look. If we were to say that what makes us pleased is beautiful, not including all pleasures, but those which come through hearing and seeing, how might we fare under contention? Presumably beautiful people, Hippias, and everything decorative, paintings and sculptures, delight us when we see them, provided they are beautiful. Beautiful sounds and music in general, and speeches and storytelling also have this same effect. And so, if we were to respond to this audacious person, “Oh well-born gentleman, the beautiful is that which is pleasant through hearing and seeing”, don’t you think we would restrain his audacity?

298a

Hippias: Well, Socrates, it seems to me, for the moment, anyway, that you are nicely stating what the beautiful is.

Socrates: What about this, Hippias? Shall we state that beautiful activities and laws are beautiful by being pleasant through hearing or seeing? Or do they possess some other form?

Hippias: Perhaps these cases might escape the man’s notice, Socrates.

298b

Socrates: By the dog, Hippias, not this man, a man before whom I would be most ashamed to speak foolishly and pretend to be talking sense when I was talking nonsense.

Hippias: Who is this man?

298c

Socrates: The son of Sophroniscus¹⁵, who would never allow me make these unexamined statements so easily, or to speak as though I know what I do not know.

Hippias: Anyway, now that you mention it, I also think myself that in the case of the laws this is something different.

Socrates: Keep quiet, Hippias, we are in danger of thinking we have found another way out when we have fallen into the same perplexity concerning the beautiful that we were in a moment ago.

Hippias: What do you mean by this, Socrates?

298d

Socrates: I will tell you what is becoming evident to me, if I am actually talking sense. These matters concerning laws and activities may perhaps prove not to be outside of perception that occurs to us through hearing and seeing. Let us, rather, persist with this argument that what is pleasant through these is beautiful, without making the laws a central issue. But if either the person I am speaking of, or anyone else at all were to ask us, “What is this, Hippias and Socrates, are you distinguishing what is pleasant in the way you describe as beautiful from the pleasant, and are you saying that what is pleasant based upon other perceptions, eating, drinking, sexual activity and everything else of that sort, is not beautiful? Or are you saying there is nothing pleasant or any pleasures at all in the likes of these, or in anything else, except seeing and hearing?” What shall we say, Hippias?

298e

Hippias: I presume we shall state emphatically, Socrates, that there are very great pleasures in the other cases too.

299a

Socrates: “Why, then,” he will say, “would you take away this name, and deprive them of being beautiful, although they are pleasures no less than the others?” We shall reply, “Because there is no one who would not laugh at us if we were to say that to eat is not pleasant, but beautiful, and that a pleasant smell is not pleasant, but beautiful. When it comes to sexual activity everyone would argue against us, I presume, that it is extremely pleasant, but if someone is to do it at all, it must be done so that no one can see, it being most base to behold. Once we have said all this, Hippias, he would probably reply, “I too understand that because people do not think they are beautiful, you are ashamed, and have been for some time, to state that these pleasures are beautiful. But I was not asking you what it is that seems to be beautiful to most people, but what is beautiful.” Well, I think we will just say what we proposed, “The part of the pleasant that arises by seeing or by hearing, is beautiful.” But do you have anything still to add to the formulation, Hippias, or should we also say something else?

Hippias: In the light of what has been said, Socrates, we need not say anything else.

299c

Socrates: “Well, you are speaking beautifully,” he will say. “Now, if what is pleasant through seeing and hearing is, in fact, beautiful, any of the pleasures that are not like this would obviously not be beautiful, would they?” Shall we agree?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: “Now, is that which is pleasant through seeing,” he will say, “pleasant through seeing and hearing, or is that which is pleasant through hearing, pleasant through hearing and seeing?” “Not at all,” we shall reply, “what is so through one would not be so through both, for that is what we think you are saying. But we said that either of these just by itself would be beautiful, and so would both.” Shan’t we reply in this way?

299d

Hippias: Very much so.

Socrates: “Well then,” he will say, “does anything pleasant differ from anything else that is pleasant, by this, by being pleasant? I am not asking if any pleasure is greater or smaller, or more or less, but if any of the pleasures differ by this alone, by one being a pleasure and the other not a pleasure?” We do not think so, do we?

Hippias: We do not.

299e

Socrates: “In that case,” he will say, “did you not select these pleasures from the other pleasures on some other basis than the fact that they are pleasures, by seeing something in both of them, that they possess something different from the others in the light of which you say they are beautiful? For presumably pleasure through seeing is not beautiful for this reason, just because it is through seeing. Indeed, if this was the reason why it was beautiful, then the other one, the pleasure through hearing, would never be beautiful. So it is not pleasure through seeing.” Shall we say that this is true?

Hippias: Yes, we shall say so.

300a

Socrates: “Neither, for its part, is the pleasure through hearing beautiful for this reason, just because it is through hearing, for in that case the pleasure through seeing would never be beautiful. So it is not pleasure through hearing.” Shall we say that the man is speaking the truth, Hippias, when he says this?

Hippias: The truth.

Socrates: “And yet, they are both beautiful, as you say”. Do we say so?

Hippias: We say so.

Socrates: “Then they possess something that is the same, something that makes them be beautiful, something common, that is present in common to them both, and to each of them individually. For presumably there is no other way they could both, and each, be beautiful.” Answer me as if you were answering him.

Hippias: I think it is as you say it is. That is my answer.

300b

Socrates: So, if both the pleasures have some characteristic that each does not have, they would not be beautiful by that characteristic.

Hippias: But how could that happen, Socrates, that there be some characteristic or other that neither of them possesses, when this characteristic which neither of them possesses is a characteristic of both of them?

Socrates: You do not think it could happen?

Hippias: If I did, I would be overtaken by considerable inexperience of the nature of these matters and the terminology of our present discussions.

300c

Socrates: How pleasant, Hippias. Well then, maybe I am in danger of thinking I see that something is the case, something you say is impossible, when I am really seeing nothing.

Hippias: It is not that you are in danger of this, Socrates. No, you are all too ready to see things amiss.

300d

Socrates: Well, many things of this kind are becoming evident before my soul, but I am not persuaded by them because they are not evident to you, a man who has made more money out of wisdom than any man alive, but to me, who, so far, has made nothing. And I am concerned, my friend, that you may be playing games with me and deceiving me intentionally when

they are so evident to me in such numbers and with such force.

Hippias: No one will know more beautifully than yourself, Socrates, whether I am playing games or not, if you would only attempt to say what it is that is becoming evident to you. For it will be evident that you are talking nonsense, since you will never find that a characteristic which neither you nor I possess is possessed by both of us.

300e

Socrates: What do you mean, Hippias? Perhaps you are talking sense, but I do not understand. But listen to me say with greater clarity what I want to say. For it appears to me that something I am not characterised as being, something I am not and you are not, is able to characterise both of us. What is more, there are others that both of us together are characterised as being, that neither of us is, individually.

301a

Hippias: You seem to be giving outrageous answers again, Socrates, even more so than your answer a moment ago. Yes, think about it. If both of us were just, wouldn't each of us be so too, or if each was unjust wouldn't both also be so, or if both were healthy, wouldn't each be so too? Or if each of us is tired or wounded or has been struck, or been affected in any other way at all, again, wouldn't both of us be affected in this way too? Then again, if we were both made of gold or silver or ivory, or, if you like, we were well-born, or wise, or revered, or aged, or indeed, young, or had any other human characteristic you please, isn't it absolutely necessary that each of us be so too?

301b

Socrates: Entirely so.

Hippias: The fact is, Socrates, you are not considering these matters as wholes, nor do those with whom you usually conduct your dialogues; you test the beautiful and each of the things that are, by taking them individually and breaking them into

pieces in words. Because of this, you are unaware of how naturally great and continuous are the bodies of being. And you are now unaware of this to such an extent that you think there is something, be it a characteristic or an essence that applies to both at the same time but not to each individually, or again, applies to each but not to both, so irrational, unreflective, simplistic and unthinking is your approach.

301c

Socrates: That is how matters stand with us, Hippias, as people are always repeating in the proverb, it is not according to a person's wishes but according to his ability. But you are our benefactor with your constant rebukes, since even now, before you rebuked us for our simplistic approach... shall I go on with the presentation and state what we have in mind about them, or shall I not speak?

301d

Hippias: You will be speaking to a man of knowledge, Socrates. For I know the approach of everybody who is concerned with speeches. Nevertheless, if it pleases you more, please speak.

Socrates: Yes, indeed, it is more pleasant. For, best of men, we were so stupid before you said all this, that we held an opinion about me and you, that although each of us is one, both of us together would not be what each of us is individually, because we are not one but two. That is how simple minded we were. But now at this stage, we have been taught otherwise by you, that if we are both two, each of us must also be two. Yet, if each is one, both must also be one. Indeed, according to Hippias, by the continuous theory of being, it cannot be otherwise, but whatever both may be, each must also be, and whatever each may be, both must be. So I have now been persuaded by you; that is where I stand. But first, remind me Hippias, are we one, you and I, or are you two, and am I also two?

301e

Hippias: What do you mean, Socrates?

302a

Socrates: Exactly what I say, for I am afraid to speak plainly to you because you get angry with me whenever you are of the opinion that you are talking sense. In any case, tell me more; isn't each of us one, and characterised in this way as being one?

Hippias: Absolutely.

Socrates: If this is the case, would each of us also be odd-numbered, or do you not consider one to be an odd number?

Hippias: I do consider it to be.

Socrates: So, being two, are we both also odd-numbered?

Hippias: That could not be so, Socrates.

Socrates: Then we are both even-numbered. Is that so?

Hippias: Absolutely.

302b

Socrates: So it is not the case that because we are both even-numbered, each of us is also even-numbered for that reason?

Hippias: Of course not.

Socrates: So it is not absolutely necessary, as you said just now, that what both are, each also is, and what each is, both also are.

Hippias: Not in such cases as these, but it is so in the cases I mentioned earlier.

302c

Socrates: That is sufficient, Hippias. Indeed, even this is satisfactory. It appears to be so in some cases and is not so in others. Yes, in fact, I said, if you recall how this discussion began, that pleasure through seeing or hearing would not be

beautiful by this, by that which characterises each of them but not both, or both of them but not each. No, because you agreed that they both and each are beautiful, they are beautiful by that by which both and each are beautiful. Because of this I thought that if both are indeed beautiful, it is by the essence that applies to both that they should be beautiful, and not by the essence that is missing from one or the other. And I still think so now. But tell me, as if starting all over again, if, in fact, pleasure through seeing and pleasure through hearing are both and each beautiful, doesn't that which makes them beautiful apply to them both and to each?

Hippias: Entirely so.

302d

Socrates: Now, is it because each and both are pleasure, is that why they would be beautiful? Or, in that case, would all other pleasures be no less beautiful than these? For, if you remember, they proved to be pleasure nonetheless.

Hippias: I remember.

Socrates: But because they operate through seeing and hearing, that is why it was said that they are beautiful.

Hippias: Yes, that's how it was expressed.

Socrates: But consider whether I am speaking the truth, for it was said, as I recall, that this 'pleasant' was beautiful, not all of it, but that which operates through seeing and hearing.

Hippias: True.

302e

Socrates: Now, doesn't this characteristic apply to both but not to each? For, presumably, as was stated previously, each of them is not through both, but both are through both, and each is not. Is this the case?

Hippias: It is.

Socrates: So it is not by this that each of them is beautiful, by what does not apply to each, for ‘both’ does not apply to each, and so according to the hypothesis it is permissible to say that they are both beautiful, but not permissible to say that each is so. Or what should we say? Isn’t this necessarily the case?

Hippias: Apparently.

Socrates: So should we say that both are beautiful, and yet say that each is not?

Hippias: What’s stopping us?

303a

Socrates: I think that what is stopping us, my friend, is that for us, there were attributes that applied to particulars in such a way that, if they were attributed to both they were also attributed to each, and if to each, also to both, all the attributes you listed. Is this so?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: But for the attributes that I listed this is not so, and these included ‘the each’ itself, and ‘the both’. Is this the case?

Hippias: It is.

303b

Socrates: Well, Hippias, to which of these does it seem to you that the beautiful belong? Does it belong with the group you mentioned? If I am strong and so are you, so also are we both; and if I am just and so are you, so also are we both; and if both are so, each is also so. In this way too, if I am beautiful and so are you, so also are we both; and if we are both, is each also so? Then there are the examples I said were occurring to me, why cannot it be like those? For instance, if certain things, both together are even, each might perhaps be odd or might perhaps be even; then again, when each is inexpressible, then both combined may perhaps be expressible, or may perhaps be

inexpressible; and there are countless other examples like this. Well, to which of these two do you assign the beautiful? Does it seem to you as it does to me? For I think it highly irrational that both of us together are beautiful while each of us is not, or that each of us is so, while both together are not so, or anything else of this kind. Do you choose this way, just like me, or the other way?

303c

Hippias: This way, Socrates.

Socrates: You are doing well, Hippias, since we may also be released from a more extensive enquiry, for if the beautiful belongs with these, then what is pleasant through seeing and hearing would no longer be the beautiful. For that which is through seeing and hearing makes both together beautiful, but not each; but this is impossible, as you and I agree, Hippias.

303d

Hippias: Yes, we agree.

Socrates: So it is impossible for what is pleasant through seeing and hearing to be beautiful, since if this becomes beautiful it presents us with one of the impossibilities.

Hippias: This is the case.

303e

Socrates: “Then, since you failed this time,” he will say, “tell me again, from the beginning, what you say this is, this beautiful that applies to both the pleasures, because of which you esteemed them above the others and called them beautiful.” Well, I think we have to say, Hippias, that they are the most harmless of the pleasures and the best, both together and each individually. Or can you suggest another way in which they excel over the others?

Hippias: Not at all. Indeed, they really are best.

Socrates: “So, then,” he will say, “are you stating that the beautiful is beneficial pleasure?” “We seem to be,” shall be my reply. And you?

Hippias: Me too.

304a

Socrates: “Now, isn’t beneficial,” he will say, “what makes something good? And what makes and what is made proved just now to be different, and so our argument goes back to the previous one, for the good would not be beautiful, nor would the beautiful be good, if each of them is indeed different.” “Entirely so,” we shall reply, Hippias, if we are of sound mind, for it is not lawful to disagree with someone who speaks aright.

304b

Hippias: But, Socrates, what do you think this all adds up to? The fact is that these are scrapings and clippings of discourse, as I said earlier, little subdivisions. But what is beautiful and really worthwhile is being able to present a speech well and beautifully in a court of law, a council chamber or before any other authority to whom you might present a speech, and having persuaded them, to depart bearing not some utterly trivial prize but the greatest prize of all, safety for yourself and for your own property and for your friends. To this one should cleave, bidding farewell to these trivial discussions lest one look like an utter fool by engaging in babbling nonsense, as you are doing now.

304c

Socrates: Friend Hippias, you are indeed blessed because you know what a man should practise, and you have engaged in the practices yourself, so you say. While I, by contrast, am gripped, it seems, by some supernatural occurrence, and so I am constantly wandering and perplexed, and once I demonstrate my own perplexity to you wise folk, I get trampled in the mire by yourselves again every time I demonstrate it. For I am told

what you have just told me, that I am busying myself with simplistic trivialities that are of no value. Then again, if I am ever persuaded by you and say what you say – that it is best by far to be able to present a speech well and beautifully in a court of law or in any other gathering – I hear nothing but abuse from this man who is constantly refuting me, and from some others hereabouts. He, in fact, happens to be my closest relative and he lives in the same house, so whenever I arrive back at my own home and he hears me saying all this, he asks if I am not ashamed at being so audacious as to discourse on the subject of beautiful activities when I have been so conspicuously refuted in relation to the beautiful that I obviously do not even know what on earth it is. “Yet how will you know,” he will say, “who does or does not present a speech or any other action whatsoever beautifully, when the beautiful is unknown to you? And when you are in such a state, do you think you are better off alive or dead?” So, as I say, that is what happens to me. I get abused and criticised by yourselves and abused by him. But, in fact, I probably need to endure all this, since, strangely, it may be beneficial. So I think, Hippias, that I have been benefited by this interaction with both of you, for I think I now understand the precise meaning of the proverb, “Whatever is beautiful is difficult.”

NOTES

1. Many scholars doubt that Plato was the author of this work.
2. Hippias of Elis was a noted sophist. In addition to the present work, he also features as the main interlocutor in Plato's *Hippias Minor*, he appears in the *Protagoras*, and is mentioned in a number of Plato's other dialogues.
3. Pittacus of Mytilene, Bias of Priene and Thales of Miletus were wise men who were counted among the Seven Sages.
4. Anaxagoras was a natural philosopher from Clazomenae in Ionia who lived a generation before Socrates.
5. Daedalus was a skilled architect and craftsman. He was said to have sculpted figures so real that they appeared to live and move.
6. Protagoras of Abdera was an influential sophist and teacher of rhetoric. He is depicted in Plato's eponymous dialogue, and positions attributed to him are considered in Plato's *Theaetetus*.
7. According to Anaxagoras, intelligence (*nous*) is the fundamental principle governing the universe.
8. The Archons were the top elected magistrates in Athens. Solon was a prominent Athenian lawgiver and statesman.
9. Neoptolemus was the son of Achilles. Nestor was the oldest among those who fought against the Trojans.
10. Six choes is equivalent to about three litres.
11. Heraclitus of Ephesus was a philosopher known for his gnomic utterances.
12. Fragment B82, Diels-Kranz.
13. Pheidias was a sculptor, painter and architect. He was noted for his gold and ivory statue of Zeus at Olympia, and the statue of Athena in the Parthenon at the Athenian Acropolis.
14. A dithyramb was a hymn sung in honour of Dionysus.
15. Socrates himself is the son of Sophroniscus.

Hippias Minor

ΙΠΠΙΑΣ ΜΙΚΡΟΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

EUDICUS of Athens, son of Apemantus

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

HIPPIAS of Elis, son of Diopheithes

scene: Phidistratus' school in Athens

363a

Eudicus: Why are you silent, Socrates, when Hippias¹ has put on such a demonstration? Why don't you join in the praise, or if you think he said something wrong why don't you challenge him? Especially since we have been left to ourselves, we who seriously claim to be involved in philosophic discourse.

363b

Socrates: Yes, indeed, Eudicus, there are matters in what Hippias said just now about Homer on which I would like to question him. For I often heard your father, Apemantus, saying that Homer's Iliad was a better poem than his Odyssey, insofar as Achilles² was a better man than Odysseus, and one of these poems features Odysseus, while the other features Achilles. So if Hippias is willing, I would gladly question him about this matter, and what he thinks of these two men, and which of the two, according to him, is better. For he has indeed presented us with a great variety of information about various poets, including Homer.

363c

Eudicus: It is obvious that Hippias won't begrudge you an answer if you ask him anything. Is this so, Hippias? If Socrates asks you something, will you answer, or what will you do?

Hippias: I would be acting most strangely, Eudicus, if I were to avoid Socrates' questioning, I who always go from my home in Elis to Olympia to the assembly of the Greeks whenever it takes place, and make myself available at the shrine to speak on request on any matters I have prepared for exhibition, and to

answer any questions anyone wishes to ask.

364a

Socrates: You are indeed in a blessed state, Hippias, if for every Olympiad you arrive at the sanctuary with such confidence in the wisdom of your soul. I would be surprised if any of the athletes who come to compete physically had such fearless confidence in respect of their bodies as you claim to have in respect of your mind.

Hippias: Yes, Socrates, that probably is the state I am in. For, ever since I began competing at the Olympics, I have never come across anyone who was better than myself in anything.

364b

Socrates: Well said, Hippias, and this reputation for wisdom that you have is a monument both to the city of Elis and to your parents. But what then can you say to us about Achilles and Odysseus? Which of them, according to you, is better, and in what respect? Indeed, when there were a lot of us inside and you were giving your demonstration, I got left behind as you were speaking because there was such a large crowd in there and I did not want to interfere with the exhibition by questioning you. But now that there are fewer of us, and Eudicus here is telling me to question you, please speak and teach us clearly. What were you saying about these two men? How were you distinguishing them?

364d

Hippias: Well, Socrates, I am willing to explain what I am saying about these men, and others too, even more clearly than before. For I maintain that Homer made Achilles the best man of those who went to Troy, he made Nestor the wisest, and he made Odysseus the wildest.

Socrates: Oh dear, Hippias. Would you do me a favour and not laugh at me if I am slow to understand what you are saying and question you repeatedly? Try rather to answer me gently and

calmly.

Hippias: Indeed, Socrates, it would be a disgrace if I, who teach these very behaviours to others and see fit to charge them for doing so, were to be inconsiderate and harsh myself when responding to your questions.

364e

Socrates: Very nicely expressed. For when you said that Homer made Achilles the best man, and Nestor the wisest, I thought I understood what you meant. But when you say that the poet made Odysseus the wiliest, to tell you the truth, I don't fully understand what you are saying. Tell me now, and perhaps I may better understand you, does Homer make Achilles wily?

365a

Hippias: Not in the least, Socrates. He is, rather, the most straightforward and the truest, since in the 'Entreaties', when he is making them converse with one another, he has Achilles say to Odysseus: "Son of Laertes, seed of Zeus, resourceful Odysseus, / I must speak out without holding back / How I shall act and how I think it will end, / For as hateful to me as the gates of Hell / Is the man who holds one thing in his heart and speaks something else. / I for my part, shall speak as it will end." In these lines he makes the character of each man plain. Achilles is true and straightforward, while Odysseus is wily and false, for he makes Achilles speak these words to Odysseus.

365b

Socrates: Now, Hippias, I may at this stage understand what you are saying. You mean that the wily person is false, or so it appears.

Hippias: Very much so, Socrates. For Homer frequently depicts Odysseus as such a person in the Iliad and in the Odyssey.

Socrates: In that case, Homer seems to think that the person who is true and the person who is false are different people and

not the same.

Hippias: How could he think otherwise, Socrates?

Socrates: And do you yourself think so, Hippias?

Hippias: Emphatically so. It would be strange if I did not.

365c

Socrates: Well, let's leave Homer aside since it is impossible to question him on what precisely he had in mind when composing these verses. But since you are apparently taking up his cause and you agree with Homer's statements as you understand them, please respond on behalf of Homer and yourself together.

Hippias: Let's do so. Ask whatever you like, briefly.

365d

Socrates: Do you maintain that false people, like sick people, lack the power to do anything, or that they have the power to do something?

Hippias: I say that they have the power, a lot of power, to do a great deal, and especially to deceive people.

365e

Socrates: According to your argument then, they are, it seems, powerful and wily. Is this so?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: And are they wily and deceptive on account of simple-mindedness and lack of intelligence, or on account of cunning and of intelligence of some sort?

Hippias: Mainly on account of cunning, but also by intelligence.

Socrates: So, they are intelligent, or so it seems.

Hippias: Yes, by Zeus, excessively so.

Socrates: And being intelligent, do they, or do they not, know what they are doing?

Hippias: They know very well, that's why they also do harm.

Socrates: And knowing whatever they know, are they ignorant or wise?

366a

Hippias: Wise, indeed, in these very matters, in deceiving.

Socrates: Come on then, let's remind ourselves of what you are saying. According to you, do those who are false have power and intelligence, and are they knowledgeable and wise in those matters about which they are false?

Hippias: I say so, indeed.

Socrates: And those who are true and those who are false are different and completely opposite to one another?

Hippias: That's what I say.

Socrates: Come on then, according to your argument, the false people are, it seems, included among those who have power and are wise.

Hippias: Very much so.

366b

Socrates: And when you say that the false people have power and are wise in these very matters do you mean that they have the power to be false if they wish, or are they devoid of power in those matters wherein they are being false?

Hippias: I think they have the power.

Socrates: To sum up, then, the false people are those who are wise and have the power to be false.

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: So, a man who is ignorant and devoid of the power to be false would not be false.

Hippias: That's it.

366c

Socrates: But anyone who can do whatever he wishes, whenever he wishes, has power. I am not referring to someone who is prevented by disease or the like, but to someone like you who has the power to write my name whenever he wishes. Don't you say that someone in such a situation has power?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: Tell me, then, Hippias, aren't you experienced in reckoning and calculation?

Hippias: Supremely so, Socrates.

Socrates: So, if someone were to ask you what number is three times seven hundred, you could, if you wished, state the truth of the matter faster and better than anyone?

366d

Hippias: Certainly.

Socrates: Because you are the most powerful and wisest in these matters?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: Now, are you merely the most powerful and the wisest, or are you also the best in these matters wherein you are the most powerful and the wisest, namely calculations?

Hippias: Of course I am also the best, Socrates.

366e

Socrates: Then you would also be most powerful at speaking the truth on such matters. Is this so?

Hippias: I think so.

Socrates: What about falsehoods on these same matters? Answer me just as splendidly and nobly as you did previously, Hippias. If someone were to ask you how much is three times seven hundred, would you be best at speaking falsehoods, and on the same matters, consistently speak falsehoods about them if you wished to be false and never give a true answer? Or might someone, ignorant of calculation, have more power to speak falsehoods than you if you wanted to? Or, on the contrary, might the ignorant fellow who wished to speak falsehoods, frequently speak the truth unintentionally, by chance, because of his lack of knowledge, while you in your wisdom, if indeed you wished to speak falsely, could consistently speak falsehoods on the same matters?

Hippias: Yes, that's it, just as you say.

367a

Socrates: Now, is the false person false about other matters but not about number? Would he not be false about numbers?

Hippias: By Zeus, he is also false about number.

Socrates: So, Hippias, should we also presume that there is such a person, someone who is false about calculation and number?

Hippias: Yes.

367b

Socrates: Now, who might this person be? If he is indeed to be false, mustn't he have the power to be false, as you have already agreed? For someone without the power to be false could never be false. That's what you said, if you remember.

Hippias: Yes, I remember. That's what was said.

Socrates: And were you not shown, just now, to have the most power to speak falsehoods about calculations?

Hippias: Yes, that's what was said.

Socrates: So, have you also the most power to speak the truth about calculations?

Hippias: Certainly.

Socrates: Therefore, the same person has the most power to speak truth and to speak falsehoods about calculations, and this is the person who is good at this, the calculator.

Hippias: Yes.

367c

Socrates: Who, then, is false about calculation, Hippias? Isn't it the person who is good at it since this very person also has the power and he is true?

Hippias: So it appears.

Socrates: Now, do you see that the same person is both true and false about these matters, and the true person is no better than the false person? For this is indeed the same person, and they are not two complete opposites as you thought earlier.

Hippias: Apparently not. Not in this case anyway.

367d

Socrates: Would you like to look at another example?

Hippias: If you like.

Socrates: Aren't you also experienced in geometry?

Hippias: I am.

Socrates: Well then, doesn't this also apply to geometry? The same person, namely the geometer, has the most power to speak falsehood or truth about the diagrams.

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: And is anyone else good at this besides the geometer?

Hippias: No one else.

367e

Socrates: Doesn't the person who is a good and wise geometer have most power to do both? If anyone at all is false about diagrams, it would be this person, the good geometer. For he has the power to speak falsely, while the bad geometer lacks that power, so that as we agreed, the person without the power to be false could not be false.

Hippias: This is so.

368a

Socrates: Well, let's look at a third case, the astronomer, whose skill you think you know better than the previous two skills. Is this so, Hippias?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: Do the same arguments apply also in the case of astronomy?

Hippias: Quite likely, Socrates.

Socrates: Then, in astronomy too, if anyone is indeed false, the good astronomer, having the power to speak falsely, will be false, and not the person who lacks this power, for he is ignorant.

Hippias: Apparently so.

Socrates: So, in astronomy too, the same person will be both true and false.

Hippias: So it seems.

368b

Socrates: Come on then, Hippias, consider all branches of knowledge and whether or not this applies generally. You are surely the wisest of all men in most subjects, as I once heard you boasting while proclaiming your own extensive and enviable wisdom at the tables in the marketplace. You said that once when you arrived at Olympia, everything you were wearing

about your person was entirely of your own making. Firstly, the ring you are wearing – you began with that – was your own handiwork, proving that you know how to engrave rings. And another seal was also your own work, as was a strigil⁴, and a flask which you yourself had fashioned. Then you said that you had cut from leather the very sandals you had on, and had woven your cloak and tunic. But what seemed most unusual to everyone, and a demonstration of your superior wisdom, was when you said that the belt of your tunic, the very one you are wearing, was just like those very expensive Persian belts, and that you had woven this yourself. What's more, you said you had brought poems with you, epics, tragedies, and dithyrambs, and lots of speeches in prose, in great variety. There you were, superior to everyone else in the subjects I just mentioned, and in correctness in rhythms, harmonies and letters, and many other matters besides these, as I seem to recall. And, indeed, I had forgotten your skill in memory, as it seems, in which you believe yourself to be most brilliant, and I suspect that I have overlooked many other examples. But what I am asking is that you look at your own skills – there are enough of them – and those of others, and let me know if you can somehow find, as you and I have agreed, a situation where the true person and the false person are distinct people and not the same person. Look for this in any wisdom or in any cunning you like, call it what you like, but you will not find it, my friend, for there is no such thing. So, please respond.

Hippias: I can't, Socrates, not offhand anyway.

Socrates: Nor, I believe, will you ever be able to. But if I am speaking the truth, Hippias, you remember what we concluded from our argument.

Hippias: I don't fully understand what you mean, Socrates.

Socrates: Perhaps you are not using your skill in memory at the moment, for you obviously think you don't need it. But I'll remind you. You know that you said that Achilles was true, while Odysseus was false and wily?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: Do you now, then, realise, the false person and the true have proved to be the same, so that if Odysseus was false, he also turns out to be true, and if Achilles was true, he also turns out to be false, and these men are not even different from one another, let alone opposites; they are, rather, alike?

369c

Hippias: Socrates, you are always weaving arguments of this sort, picking the most difficult aspect of the argument, latching onto that in minute detail, and failing to tackle the overall subject that the argument is concerned with. So now, if you wish, based upon much evidence, I'll prove to you with an adequate argument that Homer made Achilles superior to Odysseus and devoid of falsehood, while he made Odysseus a deceitful man who told many falsehoods and was inferior to Achilles. And if you wish, you, for your part, should match argument with argument, contending that the other man is superior, and then these people here will better appreciate which of us is arguing better.

369d

Socrates: Hippias, I do not dispute the fact that you are wiser than I am. But it is my constant habit to pay attention whenever anyone says anything, especially when I think that the speaker is wise. Then, because I want to understand what he is saying, I ask questions and scrutinise and compare his various statements in order to learn. But if I think the speaker is inferior, I ask no questions and I don't care what he says. And that is how you will recognise which people I regard as wise. For you will find that I am relentless about what is said by such a

person, putting questions to him so that I may benefit by learning something. When you were speaking just now, demonstrating that Achilles speaks to Odysseus as if he were a pretender in the verses you just quoted, it occurred to me that this sounds strange. If you are speaking the truth, that Odysseus, the wily, is not shown to be speaking falsely anywhere, while Achilles is shown to be a wily person, it is strange that he speaks falsely. For Achilles first speaks the lines you quoted just now: "For as hateful to me as the gates of Hell / the man who holds one thing in his heart and speaks something else." But a little later he says that he will neither be persuaded by Odysseus nor by Agamemnon, nor will he remain at Troy at all. He says rather: "Tomorrow, when I have sacrificed to Zeus and to all gods, / and loaded well my ships, and rowed out on to the salt water, / you will see, if you have a mind to it and if it concerns you, / my ships in the dawn at sea on the Hellespont where the fish swarm / and my men manning them with good will to row. If the glorious / shaker of the earth should grant us a favouring passage / the third day thereafter we might raise generous Phthia." And even before this, when he was reviling Agamemnon, he said: "Now I am returning to Phthia, since it is much better / to go home again with my curved ships, and I am minded no longer / to stay here dishonoured and pile up your wealth and your luxury." Having said all this, once in front of the entire army and again to his own companions, he is shown nowhere either preparing for his departure or even attempting to drag down his ships in order to sail home. Instead, he is shown to have a most audacious disregard for speaking the truth. Now, Hippias, I have been questioning you since we began, out of perplexity, as to which of these two men the poet makes better, and being of the view that both were excellent, I found it hard to decide who was better in terms of falsehood and truth, and in terms of excellence in general, since they are both similar in this respect.

370e

Hippias: That's because you are not looking at this in the right way, Socrates. For although Achilles speaks falsehoods, he is shown to be false not by design, but unintentionally, being compelled to remain and provide assistance because of the misfortune of the army, while Odysseus on the other hand speaks falsehoods intentionally and by design.

Socrates: You are deceiving me, my dearest Hippias, and imitating Odysseus yourself.

371a

Hippias: Not at all, Socrates. What do you mean and what are you referring to?

Socrates: The fact that, according to you, Achilles did not speak falsehoods by design, even though Homer makes him such a cheat, and, indeed, a pretender too. And so he is shown to be much more intelligent than Odysseus whom he deceives so easily without being noticed, having the audacity to contradict himself in front of Odysseus who does not even notice. In any case, Odysseus says nothing to Achilles to indicate that he is aware of his falsehoods.

371b

Hippias: What are you referring to, Socrates?

Socrates: Don't you know that when speaking later, having already told Odysseus he was going to sail away at dawn, he then told Ajax that he would do something else?

Hippias: Where?

Socrates: In the lines in which he says: "I shall not think again of the bloody fighting / until such time as the son of wise Priam, Hector the brilliant, / comes all the way to the ships of the Myrmidons, and their shelters, / slaughtering the Argives, and shall darken with fire our vessels. / But around my own shelter, I think, and beside my black ship / Hector will be held, though

he be very hungry for battle.” Well now, Hippias, do you believe the son of Thetis, having been educated by the all-wise Chiron, was so forgetful that although he had been reviling pretenders a little earlier with extreme revulsion, he first told Odysseus that he would sail away, and then told Ajax that he would stay? Surely he said this deliberately, in the belief that because Odysseus was aged, he could get the better of him by this very contrivance and falsehood?

371e

Hippias: No, I don’t think so, Socrates. In this case, he was moved by kindness to say one thing to Ajax, and something different to Odysseus. But whatever truths Odysseus speaks, he always speaks by design, and the same holds for his falsehoods.

Socrates: Then, Odysseus is, it seems, better than Achilles.

Hippias: Not in the least, Socrates.

Socrates: Why not? Just a moment ago didn’t those who intentionally tell falsehoods prove to be better than those who do so unintentionally?

372a

Hippias: But how, Socrates, could those who intentionally do injustice and who intentionally and purposely do bad deeds, be better than those who do so unintentionally? In such cases, there seems to be great leniency when someone unknowingly acts unjustly or falsely, or does something bad. Indeed, the laws are presumably much harsher towards those who intentionally act badly or falsely than they are to those who do so unintentionally.

372b

Socrates: Do you see, Hippias, that I am speaking the truth when I state how persistent I am when it comes to questioning the wise? And it is quite likely that this is the one and only good quality I possess, any others I have being significantly inferior.

For I am at a loss about things, and I don't know how matters stand. I have enough evidence for this in the fact that whenever I converse with one of you people with a great reputation for wisdom, whose wisdom is attested by all the Greeks, I am shown to know nothing. For almost nothing seems the same to me as it does to yourselves. And, indeed, is there any greater evidence of ignorance than when one differs from wise men? But I am possessed of one marvellous good quality that saves me, for I am not ashamed to learn. Rather, I enquire and ask questions and I am very grateful to whoever answers me, and I have never withheld my gratitude from anyone. Indeed, I have never denied the fact that I have learned something by pretending that what I had learned was my own discovery. Instead, I praise the person who taught me for his wisdom, and I proclaim whatever I have learned from him. And, indeed, right now I do not agree with what you are saying. In fact, I differ very strongly and I know quite well that this is my own fault, because I am the sort of person that I am, and I don't claim to be any better. For to me, Hippias, it appears, in total contradiction of what you are saying, that those who harm people and act unjustly, falsely and deceptively, not unintentionally but intentionally, are better than those who do so unintentionally. Sometimes, however, I am of the opposite opinion to this and am confused about these matters, obviously because of my not knowing. But now, at the moment, a swoon of some sort has come over me, and I am of the opinion that those who intentionally do wrong in some respect are better than those who do so unintentionally. I hold the previous arguments responsible for causing my present predicament whereby now, at the moment, it appears to me that those who unintentionally do any of these misdeeds are worse than those who do so intentionally. So please be kind to me and don't begrudge me this healing of my soul. For you will do me far more good by putting a stop to this ignorance of my soul than by curing a

physical disease. Now, if you propose to deliver a lengthy speech, I am telling you in advance that you will not cure me. But if you are willing to answer my questions as you did earlier, you will benefit me, and you yourself, I believe, will come to no harm. I might well call upon you too, dear son of Apemantus, since you have inspired me to converse with Hippias. If Hippias is unwilling to answer my questions, you should ask him to do so on my behalf.

372e

Eudicus: But, Socrates, I don't think that Hippias will need a request from us. That's not what he said initially. He said, rather, that he would not evade the questioning of any man. Is this so, Hippias? Isn't that what you said?

Hippias: I did, Eudicus, but Socrates always causes confusion in arguments and seems to be up to no good.

373a

Socrates: Hippias, best of men, at least I don't do this intentionally, in which case I would be wise and clever according to your argument. I am, rather, acting unintentionally, so you should forgive me, since, according to you, someone who unintentionally behaves badly should be forgiven.

Eudicus: Please do just that, Hippias. For our own sakes, and because of what you said at the outset, please answer any questions Socrates asks you.

Hippias: At your request I will answer. Just ask any question you wish.

373b

Socrates: Yes, indeed, Hippias, I really want to investigate the matter we are now discussing, whether those who do wrong intentionally are the better people, or those who do so unintentionally. Now, I think the most correct way to set about

the enquiry is as follows. Please answer me. Is there someone whom you call a good runner?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: And a bad runner?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: Isn't the one who runs well good, while the one who runs badly is bad?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: Doesn't the one who runs slowly run badly, while the one who runs quickly runs well?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: In a race then, and in running, speed is good while slowness is bad?

373c

Hippias: Of course.

Socrates: Now, who is the better runner, the one who intentionally runs slowly or the one who does so unintentionally?

Hippias: The one who does so intentionally.

Socrates: And to run is to do something, is it not?

Hippias: To do something, indeed.

Socrates: And if to do something, then also to perform some action, isn't this so?

373e

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: So, whoever runs badly performs this bad and disgraceful action in a race?

Hippias: Yes, a bad action, of course.

Socrates: And whoever runs slowly runs badly?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: Doesn't the good runner intentionally perform this bad and shameful action, while the bad one does so unintentionally?

Hippias: So it seems anyway.

374a

Socrates: So, in a race, the one who unintentionally performs bad actions is more base than the one who intentionally does so.

Hippias: In a race, yes.

Socrates: What about in wrestling? Who is a better wrestler, the one who falls intentionally or the one who does so unintentionally?

Hippias: The one who falls intentionally, it seems.

Socrates: And in wrestling, is it worse and more disgraceful to fall down or to throw someone down?

Hippias: To fall down.

Socrates: So, in wrestling too, the one who intentionally performs base and disgraceful actions is a better wrestler than the one who does so unintentionally.

Hippias: So it seems.

374b

Socrates: What about all activity of the body, generally? Doesn't the one who is better physically have the power to perform both actions, the strong and the weak, the shameful and the good? Consequently, whenever the one who is physically better performs bodily actions that are base, he does so intentionally, while the one who is physically worse performs them unintentionally.

Hippias: Yes, this seems to be the case in respect of physical strength too.

Socrates: What about elegance, Hippias? Isn't the better body able, intentionally, to adopt shameful and base appearances, while the more base body does so unintentionally? How does it seem to you?

Hippias: As you say.

374c

Socrates: So, inelegance too, when intentional, is associated with physical excellence, but when unintentional, with baseness.

Hippias: So it appears.

Socrates: What do you say about the voice? Which do you say is better, the one that intentionally goes out of tune or the one that does so unintentionally?

Hippias: The one that does so intentionally.

Socrates: Is the one that does so unintentionally in a worse predicament?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: And would you choose to acquire what is good or what is bad?

Hippias: What is good.

Socrates: And would you choose to have feet that are intentionally lame or unintentionally so?

374d

Hippias: Intentionally so.

Socrates: Isn't lameness a baseness and inelegance of the feet?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: What about poor sight, isn't this a baseness of the eyes?

Hippias: Yes.

374e

Socrates: So, which sort of eyes would you like to have and live with, those with which you could intentionally see dimly and abnormally, or those with which this would be unintentional?

Hippias: Those with which it would be intentional.

Socrates: So, you are of the view that any parts of yourself that intentionally perform base actions are better than those that do so unintentionally?

Hippias: Yes, at least in such cases as these.

Socrates: So, a single argument holds in all such cases as ears, nose, mouth and all the senses; those that involuntarily perform bad actions are undesirable because they are base, while those that do so intentionally are desirable because they are good.

Hippias: I think so.

Socrates: What about instruments? Is it better to use those with which you perform bad actions intentionally or unintentionally? For instance, is a rudder by which you will unintentionally steer badly better than one by which you will do so intentionally?

Hippias: The one by which you do so intentionally is better.

Socrates: Doesn't the same also hold for a bow, a lyre, for flutes, and any other examples at all?

Hippias: True.

375a

Socrates: What about a horse? Is it better to have one with a soul such that you could intentionally ride badly, or such that this happens unintentionally?

Hippias: Intentionally.

Socrates: So that soul is better?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: So, by the better soul of a horse someone may intentionally perform the base actions of that soul, while with the worse soul he does so unintentionally.

Hippias: Certainly.

Socrates: Doesn't the same hold for a dog and all the other animals?

Hippias: Yes.

375b

Socrates: What about a person? Is it better to have acquired an archer's soul that intentionally goes off target, or one that does so unintentionally?

Hippias: Intentionally.

Socrates: Isn't this soul also better at archery?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: And so the soul that unintentionally goes wrong is more base than the one that does so intentionally?

Hippias: Yes, at least in the case of archery.

Socrates: What about medical skill? Isn't the soul that intentionally performs actions that are bad for the body more skilled in medicine?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: So this soul is better at this skill than the one that does not act intentionally.

Hippias: Yes, better.

375c

Socrates: And what about the soul that is better at playing the cithara or the flute or doing anything else that involves skill and knowledge? Doesn't the better soul intentionally perform bad and shameful actions and do wrong, while the more base soul does so unintentionally?

Hippias: Apparently.

Socrates: And, indeed, we would presumably choose to acquire slaves whose souls intentionally go wrong and act badly, as they are better in these respects than those that do so unintentionally.

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: And what about our own souls? Wouldn't we wish to acquire the best ones possible?

375d

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: Won't it be better if it intentionally acts badly and goes wrong, and not unintentionally?

Hippias: But it would be terrible, Socrates, if those who intentionally do injustice are to be better than those who do so unintentionally.

Socrates: And yet that is how they appear, at least from what has been said.

Hippias: Not to me.

Socrates: But I thought they appeared so to you too, Hippias. Please respond once more. Isn't justice some sort of power or knowledge, or both? Must not justice necessarily be at least one of these?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: Now, if justice is a power of the soul, then the more powerful soul is more just, is it not? For it appeared to us, best of men, that such a soul is better.

Hippias: It appeared so, indeed.

Socrates: And what if justice is knowledge? Isn't the wiser soul more just while the more ignorant soul is more unjust?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: And what if justice is both? Isn't the soul that possesses both knowledge and power more just, while the more ignorant soul is more unjust? Isn't this necessarily the case?

Hippias: So it appears.

376a

Socrates: Didn't this more powerful and wiser soul prove to be better and to have more power to do both what is good and what is shameful in any sort of activity?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: So, whenever it performs disgraceful actions, it does so intentionally by means of power and skill, either of these, or both, apparently being attributes of justice.

Hippias: So it seems.

Socrates: And to act unjustly is to do bad, while not to do injustice is to do good.

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: In that case, won't the more powerful and better soul do injustice intentionally whenever it does so, while the base soul does so unintentionally?

Hippias: Apparently.

376b

Socrates: Is not the good man the one who has the good soul while the bad man has a bad one?

Hippias: Yes.

Socrates: So it belongs to a good man to do injustice intentionally and to a bad man to do so unintentionally, if indeed the good man has a good soul.

Hippias: Which he surely has.

Socrates: So, if there is anyone who intentionally goes wrong and does what is disgraceful and unjust, that person, Hippias, is none other than the good person.

Hippias: Socrates, on this I am unable to agree with you.

376c

Socrates: Nor can I agree with myself, Hippias. But now at least, this is how it necessarily appears to us from the argument. However, as I said earlier, I myself wander up and down and never hold the same opinions on these issues. And although it is no surprise if I or any ordinary fellow wanders, if you wise men are going to wander too, this will prove quite daunting for us, since even after we arrive in your company we shall not cease our wandering.

NOTES

1. Hippias of Elis was a noted sophist. In addition to the present work, he also features as the main interlocutor in Plato's *Hippias Major*, he appears in the *Protagoras* and is mentioned in a number of Plato's other dialogues.
2. The 'Entreaties' is the portion of the *Iliad* in which Odysseus, Ajax and Phoenix try to persuade Achilles to overcome his anger and rejoin the fight against the Trojans.
3. *Iliad* ix.308-310, 312-314. Plato does not have Hippias quote these lines exactly, and he omits a portion of the text.
4. A strigil was a bladed tool used to scrape dirt, oil and perspiration from one's body.
5. *Iliad* ix.357-363, Lattimore.
6. *Iliad* i.169-171, Lattimore.
7. *Iliad* ix.650-655, Lattimore.

Ion

ΙΩΝ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES *of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus*

ION *of Ephesus, rhapsode*

scene: unspecified public place in Athens

530a

Socrates: Greetings Ion, from where are you visiting us today? From your home in Ephesus¹?

Ion: Not at all, Socrates. No, I have come from the festival of Asclepius at Epidaurus.

Socrates: Oh, have the Epidaurians also instituted a contest for rhapsodes in honour of the god?

Ion: They have indeed, and for music and poetry in general.

Socrates: Well then, did you compete for us? How did you get on?

530b

Ion: We came away with first prize, Socrates.

Socrates: That is good to hear. Make sure that we win at the Panathenaea too.

Ion: That will happen, God willing.

Socrates: And indeed, Ion, I have often been envious of the skill of you rhapsodes. For it is always appropriate to this profession of yours that you are dressed up and look as beautiful as you possibly can. And again, we envy the fact that you need to occupy your time with various poets, lots of them, good ones too, and especially with Homer, the best and most divine of them all, and thoroughly understand his thought and not his words alone. For no one could ever be a good rhapsode unless he understood the sayings of the poet. Indeed, the rhapsode must act for the audience as an interpreter of the thought of the poet, and it is impossible to do this properly without knowing

what the poet means. And all this is enviable.

530c

Ion: That's true, Socrates. Yes, for me this constitutes the main function of my skill. Indeed, I believe that I discourse on Homer more beautifully than anyone else. And I think neither Metrodorus of Lampsacus, nor Stesimbrotos of Thasos, nor Glaucon, nor anyone else that was ever born has had so many beautiful reflections to offer on Homer as I have.

530d

Socrates: Well said, Ion. Yes, you obviously won't begrudge me a demonstration.

Ion: Yes indeed, Socrates, it is well worth hearing how nicely I have embellished Homer. I believe I deserve to be crowned with a wreath of gold by the Homerids.

531a

Socrates: And I shall indeed make time to listen to you some time, but for now please answer this question for me. Are you an expert only on Homer, or on Hesiod and Archilochus too?

Ion: Not at all, Socrates, only on Homer. I think that is enough.

531b

Socrates: And is there anything about which both Homer and Hesiod say the same things?

Ion: Yes, I think there are many.

Socrates: Now, would you better interpret what Homer says about such matters than what Hesiod says?

Ion: Well, Socrates, on matters where they say the same things, it would make no difference.

Socrates: What about matters where they do not say the same things? For example, both Homer and Hesiod have something to say about prophecy.

531c

Ion: Certainly.

Socrates: Well then, would you yourself or one of the good prophets better explain the extent to which these two poets agree about prophecy, and the extent to which they differ?

Ion: One of the prophets.

Socrates: But if you were a prophet, if you were indeed able to explain what they agree about, wouldn't you know also how to explain what they differ about?

Ion: Of course.

531d

Socrates: So, on what precisely are you an expert in relation to Homer, but not in relation either to Hesiod or the other poets? Or does Homer speak on some matters that are different from what all the other poets speak of? Doesn't Homer give accounts of warfare and the dealings with one another of good people and bad, private citizens and craftsmen, and how the gods deal with one another and with humanity, what happens in heaven and in Hades, and the births of gods and heroes? Are these not the subjects of Homer's poetry?

Ion: That's true, Socrates.

Socrates: What about the other poets? Don't they write on the same subjects?

Ion: Yes, Socrates, but they don't compose like Homer does.

Socrates: I see. Are they worse?

Ion: Much worse.

Socrates: And is Homer better?

531e

Ion: Better indeed, by Zeus.

Socrates: Well now, dearest Ion, whenever a number of people are speaking about arithmetic and one person speaks better than the others, someone will presumably recognise who the good speaker is?

Ion: I agree.

Socrates: Now, will the same person or someone else also recognise the bad speaker?

532a

Ion: The same person, I presume.

Socrates: Wouldn't that person be someone who is skilled in arithmetic?

Ion: Yes.

Socrates: What about this? Whenever a number of people are speaking about the kind of foods that are healthy, and one person speaks best, will a different person or the same person recognise that the best speaker speaks best and that the worse speaker speaks worse?

Ion: The same person, of course.

Socrates: Who is this person? What is the name for him?

Ion: A physician.

Socrates: To sum up, then, we are saying that when a number of people are speaking about the same matters, the same person will always recognise both who is speaking well and who is speaking badly. Or if the person does not recognise who is speaking badly, neither will he, of course, recognise who is speaking well on the same matter.

Ion: Quite so.

Socrates: So the same person is an expert in relation to both?

Ion: Yes.

Socrates: Now, you maintain, don't you, that Homer and the other poets, including Hesiod and Archilochus, speak about the same things but not in the same way; one speaks well, the others not so well.

Ion: Yes, and what I say is true.

532b

Socrates: Therefore, since you recognise who speaks well, you would also recognise that those who speak less well are speaking worse.

Ion: Quite likely.

Socrates: In that case, best of men, we shall not be in error if we say that Ion is as much an expert when speaking about Homer as he is when speaking of the other poets, since he himself agrees that the same person will be an adequate judge of all those who speak about the same matters, and all of the poets write, more or less, about the same things.

532c

Ion: Well then, Socrates, can you explain why, when someone discusses some other poet, I pay no attention and am unable to contribute anything of note? I simply doze off. But once someone mentions Homer, I am immediately awake, I pay attention and have plenty to say.

Socrates: This is not a difficult question, my friend. No, it is obvious to anyone that you lack the ability to speak skilfully and knowledgeably about Homer. For if you were able to speak skilfully about him you would also be able to speak about all the other poets, since poetry is presumably one whole, is it not?

Ion: It is.

532d

Socrates: Now, once someone grasps any other skill as a whole, will the same manner of enquiry apply to all of the other skills? Do you need me to explain what I mean by this, Ion?

Ion: I do, by Zeus, Socrates. Indeed, I enjoy listening to you wise men.

532e

Socrates: I wish you were speaking the truth, Ion. But it is, I believe, you rhapsodes and actors and those whose poems you recite, who are wise, while I do nothing but speak the truth like any common person. Take the question I just asked you. See how ordinary and commonplace it is. Anyone at all could understand my meaning. Is the enquiry the same once someone has understood a skill as a whole? Let's come to an understanding by means of an argument. Is there a skill of painting as a whole?

Ion: Yes.

Socrates: And there are, and there have been, many good and not so good painters.

Ion: Certainly.

533a

Socrates: Well, have you ever come across anyone who is an expert in pointing out what Polygnotus, the son of Aglaophon, paints well, and what he does not, while being unable to do so in the case of other painters? Do you know anyone who dozes off, is at a loss, and has nothing to contribute whenever anyone exhibits the works of the other painters, but is wide awake, attentive, with plenty to say when asked to give an opinion on Polygnotus or any other painter you wish, and on that one alone?

Ion: No, by Zeus. Not at all.

533b

Socrates: What about sculpting? Have you ever come across anyone who is an expert in explaining what's good about the works of Daedalus, son of Metion, or Epeius, son of Panopeius, or Theodorus, son of Zamion, or any other individual sculptor,

but is at a loss, dozes off, and has nothing to say, when faced with the works of the other sculptors?

Ion: No, by Zeus, I have not come across this either.

533c

Socrates: Then again, in the case of flute-playing, or playing the cithara whilst singing or not singing, or performing as a rhapsode, I am sure you have never come across someone who is an expert in explaining about Olympus or Thamyris or Orpheus or Phemion, the Ithacan rhapsode, while being at a loss about Ionos of Ephesus, with nothing to contribute in relation to what he performs well or ill.

533d

Ion: I am unable to argue against you on this, Socrates. But I am aware that I speak more beautifully about Homer than anyone else. I have plenty to say, and everyone agrees that I speak well. But I don't speak well about the others. So please, look at what this means.

Socrates: I am looking, Ion, and I'm going to show you what this means, in my opinion. Indeed, as I just said, your speaking well about Homer is not a skill you possess but a divine power that moves you, like the power in the stones that Euripides called Magnets and most people call Heracleon. And, indeed, the stone itself not only attracts rings that are made of iron, but also imparts power to the rings themselves so that they in turn are able to do the same thing as the stone, and attract other rings. Sometimes there is a very long chain of iron rings, but these are all suspended by the power derived from that stone. In this way, too, the Muse herself inspires people, and through these inspired people others are also inspired in a connected chain. For all our epic poets, the good ones, deliver all of their beautiful poems, not by skill, but whilst inspired and possessed. The same holds for our good lyric poets. Just as Corybantes are not in their sane mind when they dance, so too do our lyric

poets compose their beautiful melodies when they enter into the harmony and rhythm, and are frenzied and possessed like the bacchantes who draw honey and milk from the rivers whilst possessed, but not when they are in their sane mind. The soul of our lyric poets does this too, as they themselves confirm. The poets tell us, I believe, that from springs flowing with honey in some gardens and groves of the Muses, they fly like bees gathering melodies and bringing them to us, just as bees do. And what they say is true. For a poet is something light, winged and sacred, unable to compose until inspired, out of their sane mind, with reason no longer present within. But as long as anyone retains possession of this, it is impossible for such a person to compose anything or to engage in prophecy. Now, since it is not by skill but by a divine portion that they compose and have so many beautiful things to say about various matters, as you do about Homer, each of them can only compose in a beautiful manner whatever the Muse impels them to compose. In one case, this will be dithyrambs, and in another it will be encomia or dance songs or epics or iambics, and each of them will be bad at anything else. For they do not speak any of this because of skill, but because of the divine power, since, if in one case they knew how to speak beautifully by means of skill, they would also know how to do so in all other cases too. That is why the god takes reason away from them, using them as his underlings, like prophets and divine seers. This is so that we who hear them may know that the speakers, being devoid of reason, are not the ones making such valuable pronouncements. Rather, the god himself is speaking, making pronouncements to us through these people. A great proof of this argument is the example of Tynnichos of Chalcis, who never composed another work that anyone might deem worthy of mention, but he did compose the hymn that everyone sings, perhaps the most beautiful melody of all, which really is, as he says himself, “an invention of the Muses”. Indeed, I believe that

in this case in particular, the god is demonstrating to us beyond doubt that these beautiful compositions are not human productions of mere humans, but are divine compositions of gods. The poets then are nothing more than the gods' interpreters, possessed by one or other of the gods. To point this out to us, the god deliberately sang this most beautiful song through the least of our poets. Do you think this is true, Ion?

535a

Ion: Yes, by Zeus, I do indeed. For your words touch my soul, Socrates, and I believe that it is by a divine portion that the good poets interpret for us these pronouncements from the gods.

Socrates: Don't you rhapsodes, in turn, interpret for us the pronouncements of the poets?

Ion: That's true too.

Socrates: Then you are interpreters of interpreters?

Ion: Entirely so.

535b

Socrates: Well, stop there, Ion. Answer the question I'm about to ask you and hide nothing. You do well at reciting epic poems and utterly astonish your audience by singing of Odysseus leaping onto the threshold, revealing himself to the suitors and pouring forth the arrows at his feet, or of Achilles lunging at Hector, or when reciting something piteous about Hecuba or Priam. Now, when you do this, are you in your sane mind or are you outside of yourself? Does your inspired soul believe that you are in the midst of the events you are describing in Ithaca or Troy, or wherever the epics are based?

535c

Ion: The example you are giving is quite clear, Socrates. I'll hide nothing from you. Indeed, when I recount something piteous, my eyes fill with tears, and when the story is frightening or

awful, the hairs of my head stand on end from fear and my heart pounds.

535d

Socrates: Well then, Ion, are we to say that a person is sane of mind who, adorned in finery and wearing a wreath of gold, laments at sacrifices and festivals although none of his adornments are under threat? Is a person sane of mind who is fearful in front of more than 20,000 friendly people, even though none of them are robbing him or doing him wrong?

Ion: No, by Zeus, Socrates, not really, to tell you the truth.

Socrates: Now, are you aware that you rhapsodes also affect most of your audience in these same ways?

535e

Ion: I know only too well. Yes, every time I look down upon them from the stage they are weeping, looking at me in awe, sharing the astonishment of the tales. In fact, I need to pay close attention to them because if I set them weeping, I'll be laughing for the money I make, but if I set them laughing, I'll be weeping for the money I've lost.

536a

Socrates: Now, do you know that the spectator is the last of the rings I spoke of which receive from one another the power that comes from the Heracleian stone? The intermediate ring is yourself, the rhapsode, or actor, and the first ring is the actual poet. But the god, making all of these people dependent on one another for their power, through them, draws the soul of us humans to wherever he wishes. And a vast chain of dancers, teachers and tutors hangs from the side of the rings suspended from the Muse, just as they do from that original stone. One poet hangs upon one Muse, another poet upon another Muse, and we use the phrase "he is possessed", and this is well-nigh the case because he is 'held'. And from these initial rings (the poets), others in turn are hanging and are inspired from

another, some from Orpheus and others from Musaeus, but most are held and inspired by Homer. You, Ion, are one of those. You are possessed by Homer, and once any other poet is recited you fall asleep and have nothing to say. But once some strain of this poet is uttered you are immediately awake, your soul dances, and you have plenty to say. This is because you don't say what you say about Homer due to skill or knowledge, but due to possession and a divine portion. You are just like the Corybantes who are keenly aware only of the particular melody of the god who possesses them, and are well equipped with gestures and phrases for that melody, but pay no heed to the others. And, Ion, you asked me to explain why you have so much to say about Homer but not about the others. Well, this is because you are an expert advocate of Homer due to a divine portion rather than skill.

536d

Ion: Well said, Socrates. However, I would be surprised if you were to speak well enough to convince me that when I praise Homer, I do so whilst possessed or insane. And I don't think you would hold this view of me if you were to hear me speaking about Homer.

536e

Socrates: And I do want to hear you, but not before you answer the following question for me. Which of the topics dealt with by Homer are you good at speaking about? Surely not about all of them?

Ion: Mark my words, Socrates, there are no exceptions.

Socrates: Surely this is not true of the topics referred to by Homer, of which you have no knowledge?

Ion: What sort of topics does Homer speak of which I know nothing about?

Socrates: Doesn't Homer, in various places, make many references to skills? For example, about chariot driving. If I can recall the lines, I'll recite them for you.

Ion: No, I'll recite them. I certainly remember them.

Socrates: Then tell me what Nestor says to his son, Antilochus, when advising him to be careful about the turning post during the chariot race in honour of Patroclus.

537a

Ion: "...and yourself, in the well-polished chariot, lean over / a little to the left of the course, and as for your right horse, whip him / and urge him along, slackening your hands to give him his full rein, / but make your left-hand horse keep hard against the turning-post / so that the hub's edge of your fashioned wheel will seem to be / touching it, yet take care not really to brush against it..."

Socrates: That's enough. Now, Ion, who would better understand whether or not, in these lines, Homer is speaking correctly? A physician or a charioteer?

Ion: A charioteer, of course.

Socrates: Is this because he possesses that particular skill, or for some other reason?

Ion: No, it's because he has the skill.

537b

Socrates: So, has each of the skills been endowed by the god with the ability to understand some activity? For, presumably, whatever we understand through the skill of steering could not also be understood by medical skill.

Ion: Of course not.

Socrates: Nor could whatever is understood through medical skill also be understood through the skill of carpentry.

Ion: Of course not.

537c

Socrates: Isn't it the case with all skills that whatever we understand by one skill, we could not understand by another? But answer me this first. Do you agree that one skill is different from another?

Ion: Yes.

Socrates: Do you argue, as I do, that whenever there is a knowledge of various things and a knowledge of various other things, I call one knowledge a skill, and the other knowledge a different skill. Is this what you do too?

Ion: Yes.

537d

Socrates: Indeed, if knowledge were somehow a knowledge of the same things, why would we maintain that one knowledge is different from another, when the same things could be known by both? For instance, I understand that these fingers are five in number, and you understand the same thing about them as I do. And if I were to ask you if we both know the same things by the same skill, namely arithmetic, or by a different skill, you would of course maintain that it is by the same skill.

Ion: Yes.

537e

Socrates: Well, you may now answer the question I was about to ask you earlier. Do you think this is so for all skills? Are the same things necessarily understood by the same skill, while whatever is not the same is understood by a different skill? But if the skill is different, must it not also understand different things?

Ion: Yes, Socrates, that's what I think.

Socrates: Won't someone who does not possess a particular skill be unable properly to understand whatever accounts or activities are associated with that skill?

538b

Ion: That's true.

Socrates: Now, in relation to the lines you recited, would you or a charioteer better understand whether or not Homer is speaking correctly?

Ion: A charioteer.

Socrates: Presumably because you are a rhapsode, but not a charioteer?

Ion: Yes.

Socrates: And the skill of a rhapsode is different from that of a charioteer?

Ion: Yes.

Socrates: So, if it is different, it is also a knowledge of different things.

Ion: Yes.

538c

Socrates: What about the passage where Homer recounts how Hecamede, Nestor's concubine, gives the wounded Machaon a posset to drink? He says something like this: "With Pramnian wine, she grated goat's-milk cheese into it with a bronze / grater, with onion on the side as an appetizer for the drink." Does it belong to the skill of the physician or the skill of the rhapsode to fully understand aright whether or not Homer is speaking correctly in these lines.

Ion: The skill of the physician.

538d

Socrates: What about when Homer says: “She plummeted to the sea floor like a lead weight which, mounted / along the horn of an ox who ranges the fields, goes downward / and takes death with it to the raw-ravens fish.” Should we say that it belongs to the art of the angler rather than of the rhapsode to decide what he is saying and whether he is speaking correctly or incorrectly?

Ion: The angler of course, Socrates.

538e

Socrates: Then, consider this. Suppose you, as the questioner, were to ask me, “Well, Socrates, since you are finding in Homer what is appropriate for each of these skills to decide upon, please find out for me also, in the case of the prophet and prophecy, what sort of things are for the prophet to decide upon and appreciate whether Homer has composed well or ill.” Observe how easily and truly I shall reply to you. Indeed, there are numerous instances. For example, in the *Odyssey*, he recounts that the prophet Theoclymenos, a descendant of Melampus, says to the suitors: “Fortunate fellows, what evil has come upon you? Your heads and faces and / limbs are shrouded in night and darkness; a sound of wailing has broken out, / your cheeks are covered with tears. All the forecourt is huddled with ghosts, / the yard is full of them as they flock down to the underworld and the darkness. / The sun has perished out of the sky, and a foul mist has come over.” And there are many examples in the *Iliad* too – for example, in the *Battle at the Wall*, where he says: “As they were urgent to cross a bird sign had appeared to them, / an eagle, flying high and holding to the left of the people / and carrying in its talons a gigantic snake, blood-coloured, / alive still and breathing, it had not forgotten its warcraft / yet, for writhing back it struck the eagle that held it / by chest and neck, so that the eagle let it drop groundward / in pain of the bite and dashed it down in the midst of the battle

/ and itself, screaming high, winged away down the wind's blast." I shall maintain that it belongs to the prophet to consider and judge these passages and their like.

539c

Ion: What you say is true, Socrates.

539d

Socrates: And what you are saying is also true, Ion. Come on then, and do for me what I did for you. I selected, from the *Odyssey* and *Iliad*, passages that treat of the prophet and of the physician and of the angler. Now, since you have more experience of Homer than I have, Ion, you should select passages that treat of the rhapsode and the rhapsode's skill, passages that the rhapsode, more so than anyone else, should consider and judge.

Ion: All of them, Socrates. That's my answer.

539e

Socrates: All of them, Ion? That's not your answer, or are you so forgetful? And yet it would be quite inappropriate for a rhapsode to be forgetful.

Ion: What am I forgetting?

Socrates: Don't you remember agreeing that the rhapsode's skill is different from that of the charioteer?

Ion: I remember.

Socrates: Don't you agree that, being different, it would understand different things?

Ion: Yes.

Socrates: So, according to your argument, neither the rhapsode nor the rhapsode's skill will know everything.

540a

Ion: Perhaps, Socrates, with the exception of such matters as these.

Socrates: By “such matters as these” do you mean more or less anything that belongs to the other skills? But since it does not know everything, what sort of things will it know?

Ion: The sort of thing that is appropriate for a man to say, I suppose, or for a woman either, or for a slave or free man, or for a subject or someone in charge.

540b

Socrates: So, are you saying that a rhapsode will know better than a steersman the sorts of things that are appropriate for a person in charge of a ship to say when at sea in a storm?

Ion: No, a steersman knows this.

Socrates: But will the rhapsode know better than the physician what sort of thing is appropriate for someone in charge of the sick to say?

Ion: He won't know this either.

Socrates: But you say that he knows the sort of thing that is appropriate for a slave to say?

Ion: Yes.

540c

Socrates: Are you saying, for instance, that a rhapsode, rather than a cowherd, will know what sort of things are appropriate for a slave who is a cowherd to say to soothe the cattle when they are wild?

Ion: Of course not.

Socrates: Will he know the sort of things that are appropriate for a woman who spins wool to say about the working of wool?

Ion: No.

540d

Socrates: Will he know then the sort of things that are appropriate for a man who is a general to say to his soldiers

when exhorting them?

Ion: Yes, the rhapsode will know that sort of thing.

Socrates: But why? Is the skill of the rhapsode the skill of the general?

Ion: Well, I myself would at least know the sorts of things that are appropriate for the general to say.

540e

Socrates: For you are, perhaps, also skilled as a general, Ion. And indeed, if you happened to be skilled simultaneously in both horsemanship and lyre-playing, you would understand when horses are being handled well or handled badly. But what if I were to ask you, Ion, by what skill you understand that horses are being well handled? Is it by the skill of the horseman or the skill of the lyre player? How would you answer me?

Ion: By the skill of the horseman. That would be my reply.

Socrates: Now, if you also recognised those who play the lyre well, you would accept that you do so by means of your skill as a lyre player, not by your skill as a horseman,

Ion: Yes.

Socrates: When you understand military matters, are you doing so by means of your skill as a general or as a good rhapsode?

Ion: I don't think there is any difference.

541a

Socrates: How so? You say there is no difference. Are you saying that the rhapsode's skill and the general's skill are one, or are they two?

Ion: In my opinion, they are one.

Socrates: So, anyone who is a good rhapsode turns out to be a good general too?

Ion: Very much so, Socrates.

Socrates: Therefore, anyone who happens to be a good general is also a good rhapsode.

Ion: No, I don't agree with that.

541b

Socrates: But you do agree that anyone who is a good rhapsode is also a good general?

Ion: Certainly.

Socrates: Aren't you the best rhapsode of all the Greeks?

Ion: By far, Socrates.

Socrates: And also the best general of all, Ion?

Ion: Of that you may be sure, Socrates, and I have learned this from Homer.

541c

Socrates: Why then, by the gods, Ion, do you go around Greece as a rhapsode and not as a general, when you are both the best rhapsode of all the Greeks and the best general too? Or do you think that the Greeks have a great need for a rhapsode crowned with a wreath of gold, but no need for a general?

Ion: Well, Socrates, our city is under the rulership and military command of your city and has no need for a general, and neither your people nor the Spartans would choose me as a general because they think that they have enough themselves.

Socrates: Ion, my good man, you do know Apollodorus of Cyzicus?

Ion: Who is he?

541d

Socrates: A man whom the Athenians have often chosen for themselves as a general, even though he is a foreigner. And this

city appoints Phanosthenes of Andros and Herakleides of Clazomenae to military command and other positions of authority, proving that they are noteworthy even though they are foreigners. So why would Ion of Ephesus not be chosen as a general, and respected, if he too seems worthy of note? You Ephesians were originally Athenians, were you not, and Ephesus is a city second to none? But in fact, Ion, if your claim to be able to praise Homer with knowledge and expertise is actually true, you are doing me an injustice. You promise me that you have knowledge of the manifold beauties of Homer, and you say that you will demonstrate them. But you deceive me and you fall far short of demonstrating them, and you are not even prepared to explain on what matters you are an expert, even though I have been imploring you for some time. You are much like Proteus¹¹, assuming all sorts of forms, turning this way and that, until finally you escape me by appearing in the guise of a general to avoid demonstrating your expertise in the wisdom of Homer. Now, if you have expertise in Homer, then, as I said just now, by promising to give me a demonstration you have deceived me, and you are acting unjustly. However, there is no injustice if you have no expertise but are describing the manifold beauties of the poet possessed, as I said, by a divine portion from Homer, while knowing nothing. So, decide whether you want us to regard you as an unjust man or as divine.

542a

Ion: There is a big difference Socrates. Indeed, the divine is regarded as better by far.

542b

Socrates: In that case, Ion, we grant you this better portion – to be divine and not to praise Homer based on some expertise.

NOTES

1. Ion was a rhapsode from Ephesus in Asia Minor, which at the time was a colony of Athens. He specialised in the works of Homer.
2. Metrodorus of Lampsacus, Stesimbrotos of Thasos, and Glaucon of Rhegium were all prominent interpreters of Homer.
3. The Homerids were a guild of rhapsodes.
4. This reflects the idea that natural magnets were thought to come from the region that included Magnesia and Heraclea, from which they derived their names.
5. Those who worshipped Bacchus would dance themselves into a frenzy in which they would find rivers flowing with milk and honey.
6. Iliad xxiii.335-340, Lattimore (adjusted to conform to Plato's text).
7. Iliad xi.639-640, Lattimore.
8. Iliad xxiv.80-82, Lattimore.
9. Odyssey xx.351-357, Lattimore.
10. Iliad xii.200-207, Lattimore.
11. Proteus was an early sea god. He was associated with the changeability of the seas and other bodies of water, and was thus depicted as being able to take any shape he wanted. Odyssey iv.385 ff.

Laches

ΛΑΧΗΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

LYSIMACHUS a well-educated Athenian

NICIAS an Athenian politician and general

LACHES an Athenian general

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

MELESIAS a friend of Lysimachus

scene: the dialogue follows an exhibition of fighting in armour

178a

Lysimachus: Nicias¹ and Laches, you have seen the man fighting in armour, but we did not tell you at the time why myself and Melesias here invited you to see him with us, but we shall tell you now. Indeed, we believe that it is necessary to speak openly, especially to the two of you. Now, there are some people who are contemptuous of this sort of thing, and if anyone asks them for advice they will not say what they think. Instead they try to guess what advice the person wants, and they say something that is contrary to their own opinion. But we believe that you are men of ample discernment, and based on this discernment you should tell us, in plain terms, what you think about the issues we are about to set before you. Now, the issue that I am leading up to at such length is as follows. We both have these sons: this is my friend's son who bears the name of his grandfather, Thucydides; and this is my son who also bears his grandfather's name, since we call him Aristides, after my father. Now, we have resolved to care for them as best we can, and not to do what most parents do when their sons reach adolescence and allow them to do whatever they wish. No, we have decided to make an immediate start at caring for them as best we can. So, realising that the two of you also have sons, we believed you, if anyone, cared about how they might, with attention, become as excellent as they possibly could. And if it turns out that you have not often thought about this sort of thing, we remind you that it should not be neglected and we

invite you to join us in devising some means of caring for our sons. But, Nicias and Laches, you should also hear how we came to these decisions, even if it takes a little longer. In fact, Melesias and I take our meals together and the two lads dine with us. Now, as I also said at the beginning of our conversation, we are going to speak openly to you. For in the case of his own father, each of us can recount numerous noble achievements to the young men, some performed in time of war, some in times of peace, as they managed the affairs of our allies and of this city of ours. But when it comes to our own achievements, neither of us has anything to report. So we are ashamed of this in front of the boys, and we blame our own fathers for allowing us free rein once we reached adolescence while they were busy with other people's affairs. So we point all this out to the young men, explaining that if they show no care for themselves and pay no heed to us, they will not be famous, while if they do care for themselves they may, perhaps, become worthy of the names they bear. Now, they say that they will heed us, while we for our part are considering what particular subjects or pursuits would render them as excellent as they could possibly be. Now, someone introduced us to this subject of fighting in armour, as a good subject for a young man to learn, and he praised this fellow whose exhibition you have just seen, and then told us to go and see it. So we decided we should go to see the man, and take you two along with us to see him too, and at the same time to be our advisors and, if you wish, co-operate with us in the care of our sons. That's what we wanted to set before you. So at this stage we want you, for your part, to advise us about this particular subject, and whether it should be learned or not, and whether there is any other subject you can recommend for a young man, or any pursuit either. And please tell us how you will respond to the proposed co-operation.

179d

Nicias: As for myself, Lysimachus and Melesias, I applaud your idea, and I am ready to cooperate, and I think Laches here will do so too.

179e

Laches: Yes, that's true, Nicias. And what Lysimachus said just now about his own father and Melesias' father too is, in my opinion, very relevant to them, to the two of us, and to everyone who engages in civic affairs, because almost as a rule what happens to them is just what he described. Whether it concerns their children or anything else, they set little value upon their private affairs, and manage them without proper care. Now, although you are explaining this very well, Lysimachus, I am surprised that you are calling upon the two of us as advisors on the education of the young men, and not calling upon Socrates here, who in the first place is from your own district, and secondly, whenever time is being spent on the sort of worthwhile subjects or pursuits for young men that you are seeking, Socrates is there.

180a

Lysimachus: What do you mean, Laches? Has Socrates here demonstrated an interest in this sort of thing?

Laches: Yes, certainly, Lysimachus.

180b

Nicias: I can tell you about this too, just as well as Laches can. In fact, Socrates recently recommended a music teacher to me for my own son. His name is Damon², a pupil of Agathocles, and the most accomplished of men, not only in music, but in anything else you might deem worthwhile for young men to engage in at that age.

180c

Lysimachus: Well, Socrates, Nicias, and Laches, men of my age do not really understand young people any more, since we spend most of our time at home because of our age. But if you,

son of Sophroniscus, have any good advice to give to someone from your own district, then you should advise me. It is only right that you should. In fact, it so happens that you are my friend, through your father, since myself and your father were friends and associates, and to the day he died he never fell out with me. But something is coming back to me, and I am reminded from what has just been said, that when the young lads here are conversing with one another at home, they often mention Socrates, and they praise him highly. Yet I never asked them if they are referring to the son of Sophroniscus. So, boys, tell me, is this the Socrates you mention so often?

180d

Boys: Certainly, father. This is the man.

180e

Lysimachus: Well, by Hera, Socrates, it is good to see that you do right by your father, the best of men, especially in view of the mutual family connections that are about to be established between ourselves.

181a

Laches: Yes, indeed, Lysimachus, you should not let this man go. For I have also seen him elsewhere, doing right not only by his father but by his fatherland too. Yes, he retreated alongside me in the flight from Delium³, and I am telling you that if the others had been prepared to act as he acted, our city would be standing tall, and a calamity like that would never have befallen her.

181b

Lysimachus: This is fine praise indeed, Socrates, since it comes from trustworthy men, and because of the qualities they are praising in you. Now, rest assured that when I hear all this I am delighted that you are held in high esteem, and you should count me among those who have the highest regard for you. Now, you yourself really should have paid us a visit long before this and treated us as family. It is only right that you should. But

from now on, since we now recognise one another, you have no choice but to get to know us, and make the acquaintance of ourselves and these young fellows here, so that you may preserve our mutual friendship. Well, you will do this of course, and we shall remind you again. However, what do you have to say about our initial discussion topic? What do you think? Is the subject suitable for the young men or not, I mean learning how to fight in armour?

181d

Socrates: Well, Lysimachus, I shall try to advise you about this matter as best I can, and what is more, I shall also do everything else you are asking me to do. However, since I am younger than anyone else here, and less experienced than they are, I think that what is most fitting is that I first listen to what they say and learn from them. Then, if I have anything to add to what they say, I should provide instruction at that stage, and try to convince yourself and these men too. Well, Nicias, why does one of you not speak first?

181e

Nicias: There is no reason not to, Socrates. Indeed, it seems to me that knowledge of this subject is of benefit to the young in lots of ways. In fact, it would be well for the young people to spend their time in this, rather than the pursuits they normally like to engage in when they are at leisure. This must improve their bodies, for it is just as good and just as strenuous as any physical exercise, and, at the same time, this exercise, and horsemanship too, are most appropriate to a free man. For only those who exercise with these instruments of war are trained in the struggle in which we engage and in the instruments upon which our struggle depends. What's more, this subject will also be of some benefit in the battle itself, when it is necessary to fight in ranks alongside many others. However, its greatest benefit is when the ranks are broken and you must then fight one on one, either when pursuing someone who is warding off

your attack, or when you yourself are in retreat and must ward off an attack by someone else. Someone with knowledge of this subject would suffer no harm when faced with a single opponent, or perhaps when faced with many. He would have the advantage in any situation. Then again, something like this also awakens an interest in another noble subject, for everyone who learns how to fight in armour would also develop an interest in the related subject of military tactics, and once he had grasped these and taken pride in them, he might then tackle the subject of generalship. And it is obvious by now that anything related to these, and all the subjects and pursuits that are noble and well worthwhile for a man to learn and practise, would all have their origin in this subject. But we should make an additional point, and it is not an insignificant one. This knowledge would make any man much bolder and braver in battle than he was before. And we should not disdain to mention, even if some think it is insignificant, that he will look more impressive where a man needs to look more impressive, where he needs to appear more formidable to the enemy because of his impressive appearance. So, Lysimachus, it seems to me, as I say, that these subjects should be taught to young men, and I have told you why I think so. But if Laches has a contrary view, I would gladly listen to it.

182d

Laches: Well, Nicias, to take any subject at all and say that it should not be learned presents a difficulty, since it does seem good to know everything. And if this armour business is indeed a subject, as its instructors claim and as Nicias says, then it should be learned. But if it is not a subject, and those who promise to teach it are deceiving us, or if it is actually a subject but not a very serious one, what need could there be to learn it? And I am saying this about it based upon the following observation: I think that if it amounted to anything it would not have been overlooked by the Spartans, people whose sole

concern in life is to seek out and practise any subject or pursuit that might give them an advantage over others in war. And if these people have overlooked it, then the teachers of this subject surely have not overlooked the fact that, among the Greeks, the Spartans are the ones who are most serious about such matters, and that anyone who has won respect among them in this area would also make a great deal of money from the other cities, just as a tragedian does when he has won respect among ourselves. As a result, anyone who thinks that he is a good tragedian does not make a circuit of Attica, putting on performances in all the other outlying cities. No, he makes his way here directly and puts on a performance for us. It is the reasonable thing to do. But I observe that those who fight in armour regard Sparta as sacred ground, and they do not set even a toe there. They make their way around the city in a circle and would prefer to put on a performance for anyone else at all, especially for those who would confess that when it comes to warfare, lots of other cities are superior to themselves. And, Lysimachus, I have come across quite a few of these people in action and I have seen what they are like. So we may also consider the matter on this basis. Indeed, as a rule, not a single person who has practised fighting in armour has ever won fame in battle. Even though, in all the other disciplines, the people who become famous are the ones who practise, these fellows, in contrast it seems, meet with stark misfortune. Yes, and this Stesilaus, whom you saw along with me, putting on that performance in front of such a large crowd and making those great claims that he made about himself, well, I saw him elsewhere, in a real battle, actually putting on a better performance unintentionally. The ship he was serving on had rammed a transport vessel and he was fighting with an unusual weapon, a 'spear-pike' – as unusual as the man himself. Now, his general exploits are hardly worth recounting, except for the details of what happened to the spear-pike. For as he was

fighting, it somehow got caught in the rigging of the other ship and wouldn't budge. So Stesilaus tugged at it in an effort to free it but he was not able to, and the ships were moving. Well, at first he ran along the deck, holding onto the weapon, but then the other ship began to draw away and it dragged him after it, still holding on. He allowed the weapon to slip through his hands until he was left holding onto the end of the shaft. There was laughter and derisory applause from the men on the transporter at the sight of the fellow, and when someone threw a stone that landed on the deck at his feet, he finally let go of the spear-pike. By then, even the men on his own ship were no longer able to contain their laughter when they saw his weapon flapping about on the transporter. Now, all this may perhaps amount to something, as Nicias says, but those whom I have met are people like Stesilaus. So, as I said initially, whether it is a subject but of little benefit, or it is not a subject but people claim that it is and pretend that it is, in either case it is not worth trying to learn it. In fact, it seems to me that if a coward were to believe that he knew this subject, he would become bolder because of it, and the sort of man he actually is would become more obvious, while if a brave man were to do so, he would be under scrutiny from everyone else and would attract enormous criticism at even the slightest mistake. For pretensions to this sort of wisdom produce envy, and unless a man excels over others in excellence to an amazing extent, there is no way he can avoid becoming a laughing stock by claiming to possess this knowledge. Such is my opinion, Lysimachus, of any effort expended upon this subject. But as I told you initially, you should not let Socrates here go, but you should ask for his advice, based on his view of the issue before us.

184c

Lysimachus: Well, I am asking you, Socrates. In fact, our meeting seems to me to require a sort of casting vote. For if these two men had concurred, there would be less need for this,

but now, as you see, Laches has voted the opposite way to Nicias, so it would be nice to hear from you too. Which of the two men do you vote with?

184d

Socrates: What's this, Lysimachus? Are you going to adopt the stance that the majority of us approve of?

Lysimachus: What else could anyone do, Socrates?

184e

Socrates: And you, Melesias, would you do the same? Even if you had a meeting about how your son should exercise for a competition, would you be persuaded by the majority of us or by that person who happens to have been educated and exercised under a good trainer?

Melesias: By that person, Socrates, more likely.

Socrates: So, would you be more persuaded by him than by the four of us?

Melesias: Probably.

Socrates: Because, I presume, an issue should be decided based upon knowledge rather than numbers, if it is to be decided aright.

Melesias: Of course.

185a

Socrates: So, in this case too, we should first consider this particular question. Is there or is there not anyone among us who is skilled in the matter we are deliberating upon? And if there is, we should be persuaded by that one person and bid the others farewell. But if there is not, we should search for someone else to advise us. Or do you and Lysimachus think that what is now at stake is insignificant and does not concern what is actually the most important of your possessions? For, I believe, the entire estate of the father will be managed based

upon the sort of people the children become, and whether or not the sons turn out well.

Melesias: That's true.

Socrates: So it must be given a great deal of forethought.

Melesias: Certainly.

185b

Socrates: Now, on the issue I just mentioned, how would we proceed if we wished to consider which of us is most skilled in the area of competitive contests? Would he not be the person who has learned and practised, and who has had good teachers of this particular skill?

Melesias: I think so.

Socrates: Even before that, should we not consider what this subject, whose teachers we are seeking, actually is?

Melesias: What do you mean?

Socrates: Perhaps this will be more obvious as follows. I do not think we agreed at the outset what exactly it is that we are deliberating about and considering when we ask who among us is skilled in this, and who has acquired teachers for the sake of this, and who has not.

185c

Nicias: But, Socrates, aren't we discussing armour fighting and whether the young men should learn this or not?

185d

Socrates: Yes, certainly, Nicias, but when someone is considering a medicine for his eyes, and whether it should be applied or not, do you think his deliberation at that time is about the medicine or his eyes?

Nicias: It is about his eyes.

Socrates: And when someone is considering a bridle for a horse, and whether it should be attached or not, and when this should happen, presumably he is then deliberating about the horse, and not about the bridle.

Nicias: True.

Socrates: So, in a word, whenever someone considers something for the sake of something else, his deliberation is actually about that other thing. His deliberation is not concerned with whatever he was considering for the sake of that other thing.

Nicias: Necessarily.

Socrates: So, we should consider whether the advisor is skilled in attending to that, namely to that for the sake of which we are engaging in these considerations.

Nicias: Certainly.

185e

Socrates: So, at present we claim to be considering a subject for the sake of the souls of the young men, do we not?

Nicias: Yes.

Socrates: So we should consider if there is anyone among us who is skilled in attending to the soul, and is able to attend to it aright, and if there is anyone who has had good teachers?

Laches: What's this, Socrates? Have you not noticed that in some cases people have become more skilled without teachers than with teachers?

Socrates: I have, Laches, but you would not be prepared to believe them if they claimed to be good practitioners unless they were able to present you with one or more well-executed deeds, born of their own skill, as evidence.

Laches: There you speak the truth.

186a

Socrates: So, Nicias and Laches, since Lysimachus and Melesias have called upon us to advise them about their two sons, being eager that their souls turn out as excellent as they possibly can, we, if we claim to have teachers, should show them the ones who are themselves good in the first place, and have attended to the souls of many young men, and secondly, have evidently given instruction to ourselves. Alternatively, if any one of us declares that he himself has not had a teacher but can recount some deeds of his own, then he should point out any Athenians or strangers, slaves or free men, who are generally acknowledged to have become good through his agency. But if none of this applies to us, we should bid them look for someone else, and not run the risk of corrupting the sons of our companions and incurring enormous reproach from our closest kin. Now, Lysimachus and Melesias, I am the first to admit that I myself have not had a teacher of this, even though I set my heart on the matter from my earliest years. But I cannot afford to pay money to the sophists, the only people who proclaimed that they could make me noble and good, and I am unable, to this day, to discover the skill for myself. Yet I would not be surprised if Nicias or Laches have discovered it or learned it. In fact, they are wealthier than I am, and so they may have learned from others, and indeed they are older, so they may have discovered it already. Now, I think they are able to educate a person, for they would never have expressed their views so fearlessly on the pursuits that are useful or harmful for the young unless they were convinced that they had sufficient knowledge. And although in general I believe them, I was surprised that they disagreed with one another. So, Lysimachus, I ask this of you in return. Just as Laches directed you a moment ago not to let me go, but to question me, I am now recommending that you do not let Laches and Nicias go, but ask them this question. Socrates denies that he has any knowledge

of this matter, or that he is competent to decide which of you is speaking the truth, for he has neither discovered this sort of thing nor learned about it from anyone else. So, Nicias and Laches, you should tell us who is the most formidable person you have consulted in relation to the rearing of your sons; whether you are knowledgeable because you learned from someone else, or because you found out for yourselves; and if you did learn it, who were your teachers and who else has the same skill they have? We ask this in case you are too busy with affairs of state, in which case we could go to these people and persuade them, with gifts or favours or both, to take charge of our children, and yours too, so that they do not turn out badly and bring shame upon their ancestors. But if you have discovered this sort of thing yourselves, give us an example of some people whom you have already made good and noble through your care when they had previously been bad. For if you are now about to educate people for the first time, you should be careful lest you run risks, not with some worthless person, but with your own sons and the children of your friends, and simply end up, as the saying goes, practising pottery on too large a vessel. So, tell us which of these applies to you, and is appropriate in your case, and which is not. Find this out from them, Lysimachus, and do not let these men off.

187c

Lysimachus: Gentlemen, although Socrates has, in my opinion, spoken well, you, Nicias and Laches, should decide for yourselves whether you wish to be questioned on such matters and give an account of them. Now, Melesias and myself would, of course, be delighted if you were willing to give a full response to everything that Socrates asked. In fact, I said at the very outset that we were going to invite you to advise us on this issue because we thought you were likely to care about this sort of thing, especially since your own children, just like ours, are almost of an age to be educated. So, if it makes no difference to

you, speak, and consider this, along with Socrates, in the give and take of discourse with one another. For his point is well made; we are now deliberating about our most important possessions. So take a look and decide if this is what should be done.

187e

Nicias: Lysimachus, you seem to me, in truth, to know Socrates only through his father, and not to have associated with the man himself except when he was a child, when you came across him among the local people, as he accompanied his father to the temple or some other public gathering. But it is obvious that you are still unacquainted with the man in his mature years.

Lysimachus: What makes you so sure, Nicias?

Nicias: You seem to me to be unaware that whoever gets close to Socrates and engages in a dialogue with him must necessarily, even if he starts off by discussing something else at first, be led around by this man relentlessly in the discussion until he submits to giving an account of himself, the manner in which he is living his life at present, and how he has lived his life until now. And once he submits, Socrates will not let him go until he tests all this, well and truly. Now, I am used to him, and I know that it is necessary to undergo this process at his hands, and yet I know quite well that I too shall undergo this. Indeed, Lysimachus, I delight in engaging with the man, and I think there is no harm in being made aware that we have acted, or are acting, badly. Rather, a person who does not flee from these processes, but willingly embraces the maxim of Solon, and values learning for as long as he lives and does not presume that old age of itself brings good sense, he must necessarily be more careful about the rest of his life. For me, there is nothing strange or unpleasant in being tested by Socrates. I more or less knew a while ago that with Socrates present the conversation would not be about our sons, but about ourselves. So, as I say,

there is no reason for me not to converse with Socrates in whatever way he wishes. But you should see where Laches here stands on the matter.

188c

Laches: Nicias, my attitude to discussions is simple, or if you prefer, not simple, but twofold. In fact, someone might think me a lover of discourse, and then again a hater of discourse. For whenever I hear a man discoursing on the subject of excellence or any sort of wisdom, a true man who is worthy of the words he is speaking, I am delighted beyond measure when I see that both the speaker and the words spoken are mutually appropriate and in harmony. And such a person seems genuinely musical to me, attuned to the noblest harmony, not of a lyre or instruments of entertainment, but in truth he makes his own life a concord of words with deeds, attuned not, I believe, to the Ionic mode, nor to the Phrygian nor the Lydian, but to the Doric mode, which is the only harmony that is indeed Greek. When a man like this speaks, he makes me happy, and anyone would think me a lover of discourse because I accept what the man says so eagerly. But someone who behaves in the opposite way pains me, and the better he seems to speak, the greater the pain, and he makes me seem, in turn, to be a hater of discourse. Now, I'm not acquainted with Socrates' words, but it seems that I do have previous experience of his deeds, and therein I found him worthy of noble words and total freedom of speech. So, if he also has this quality, we are like-minded, and I would gladly submit to scrutiny by such a man as this, and would not be reluctant to learn from him, since I too agree with that precept of Solon, with just one reservation: I am willing to grow old, learning a lot in the process, but only from worthy men. Let Solon concede this point to me, that my teacher should also be good, so that I do not turn out to be a difficult pupil with a distaste for learning. But if my teacher is to be younger than I am, or is not yet famous or has some other shortcoming of that

kind, that does not concern me. So, Socrates, I invite you to teach me and refute me in whatever way you please, and also to learn, in turn, anything that I know, such is the regard I have for you ever since that day when you were my companion in danger and gave proof of your own excellence – the sort that a man who intends to do justice to himself ought to give. So say anything you like and do not take account of our age difference.

189a

Socrates: It seems we cannot accuse you two of being reluctant to give advice and join our enquiry.

189b

Lysimachus: But it's our work you are doing, Socrates, for I count you as one of us, so take my place on behalf of the young men and make the enquiry. Find out whatever we need to know from these gentlemen, and then act as our adviser by discussing it with the boys. For I am inclined nowadays, because of my age, to forget for the most part the questions I intend to ask, and any answers too, and if other arguments are introduced during the process my memory goes completely, so you should do the talking. Go through the issues we are interested in among yourselves. I shall listen in, and then I, along with Melesias here, shall do whatever you suggest.

189c

Socrates: Nicias and Laches, we should comply with this request of Lysimachus and Melesias. Now, a moment ago we set about considering what instructors we have had in this kind of education, and what other people we have made better. Perhaps we would do well to investigate such questions ourselves. But I think the following enquiry leads to the same thing, and to an extent it proceeds more from principle. So if we happen to know, in relation to anything at all, that its presence in something makes that in which it is present better, and furthermore we are able to make it be present in that, it is obvious that we know the thing itself, that's the matter on

which we would be acting as advisers on how it might best and most easily be acquired. Perhaps you do not understand what I am saying, but you shall understand more easily from the following. If we happen to know that if sight is present to the eyes it makes those eyes in which it is present better, and if we are also able to make it present in eyes, it is obvious that we know exactly what sight is. And sight is the subject on which we would be acting as advisers on how it might best and most easily be acquired. For if we did not know what exactly sight itself was, or hearing either, we could hardly act as worthy advisers and physicians in relation to eyes or ears, and the manner in which someone might best acquire hearing or sight.

190b

Laches: That's true, Socrates

Socrates: Well, Laches, are there not two men now inviting us to counsel them on the manner in which their sons may be made better by the presence of excellence in their souls?

Laches: Certainly.

Socrates: Well then, the first thing we need is this. We need to know what precisely excellence is, do we not? For if, somehow, we were totally ignorant as to what precisely excellence happens to be, how could we act as advisers to anyone on how it may best be acquired?

190c

Laches: I don't think we could do so at all, Socrates.

Socrates: However, we do say that we know what it is, Laches.

Laches: Yes, we say so.

Socrates: And in the case of what we know, we could of course also, surely, say what it is.

Laches: Of course.

Socrates: Well, excellent man, let us not consider excellence as a whole straight away, since that task is probably beyond us. But let us first see if we have sufficient knowledge of some part of it. Then the enquiry will, in all likelihood, be easier for us.

190d

Laches: Then let us do as you suggest, Socrates.

Socrates: So, which of the parts of excellence should we choose? Or is it obviously the one that learning how to fight in armour seems to promote? And most people presumably think it promotes courage. Is this so?

Laches: Yes, indeed, very much so.

190e

Socrates: In that case, Laches, we should first attempt to state what exactly courage is. Then, after that, we shall also consider the manner in which it may become present in young people, insofar as it can become present through the pursuits they engage in and the subjects they learn. So, as I say, try to state what courage is.

Laches: By Zeus, Socrates. There is no difficulty in stating that if someone were prepared to remain at his post, ward off the enemy and not run away, then mark my words, he would be courageous.

Socrates: That is nicely put, Laches, and perhaps I am to blame for not expressing myself more clearly, but you have not answered the question I had in mind. You have answered a different one.

Laches: What do you mean by this, Socrates?

191a

Socrates: I shall tell you, if I can. Presumably that man is courageous, the one you describe, the one who remains at his post and fights the enemy.

Laches: Yes, that's what I am saying.

Socrates: And so am I. But what about someone who fights the enemy whilst fleeing rather than remaining at his post?

Laches: Fleeing in what sense?

191b

Socrates: Presumably in the sense that the Scythians are said to fight whilst fleeing, no less than they do in pursuit. And Homer, in praise of the horses of Aeneas, says that they knew how to pursue and also to flee very swiftly, hither and thither. And he praises Aeneas himself for his knowledge of flight, and he refers to him as a 'counsellor of flight'.

Laches: And rightly so, Socrates, since he was referring to chariots, and you are talking about the Scythian horsemen. But although the cavalry fight in that way, the men at arms fight in the way I am describing.

191c

Socrates: Except perhaps for the Spartans, Laches. Indeed, they say that when the Spartans at Plataea came across the men with the wicker shields, they were not willing to remain in position and do battle with them, so they fled. But once the Persian ranks had broken, they turned around and fought, just as horsemen do, and so won the battle of Plataea.

Laches: That's true.

Socrates: Well, this is what I meant earlier, that I am responsible for the fact that you did not answer properly because I did not ask the question properly. Indeed, I wanted to find out from you not just who are courageous among the infantry, but also among the cavalry and the entire warrior class; and not only who are courageous in battle, but also amidst perils at sea; and who are courageous in the face of disease or poverty or political issues. And furthermore, I also wanted to find out who are courageous not only when faced with pain or

fear, but also who are formidable at combatting desire or pleasure, either by standing firm or rallying against them. For I presume, Laches, there are some people who are courageous in such situations as these.

Laches: Very much so, Socrates.

191d

Socrates: So all these people are courageous, but some possess courage in the face of pleasures, others in the face of pain or desire or fear, while others I believe display cowardice in the same situations.

Laches: Entirely so.

191e

Socrates: What exactly are these two, courage and cowardice? That is what I wanted to find out. So try once more to state firstly what courage, which is the same in all these instances, actually is. Or do you not fully understand what I am saying yet?

Laches: Not entirely.

Socrates: What I mean is this. It is as if I were asking what exactly speed is, which we encounter in running, in harp-playing, in speaking, in learning – a quality we exhibit to an extent in any activity worth mentioning, of hands, legs or mouth, and in speech and thought too. Is this how you speak of it too?

Laches: Very much so.

192a

Socrates: Well, if someone were to ask me, “Socrates, what do you say this quality is, the one you refer to as speed in all these examples?” I would tell him that I call speed the power that gets a lot done in a short time, whether in speech or running or in anything else.

Laches: And you would be right to say so.

Socrates: Now, Laches, you should also try to describe courage in this way. What power, the same in the case of pleasure and in the case of pain, and in all the other examples we gave a moment ago, is referred to as courage?

192b

Laches: Well, it seems to me to be an endurance of the soul, if I must describe what naturally applies to them all.

Socrates: But of course we must, if we are to answer the question we put to ourselves. Yet it appears to me that you certainly do not, as I see it, regard all endurance as courage. I justify this assertion as follows: I know fairly well, Laches, that you count courage among the qualities that are utterly noble.

Laches: Among the very noblest, rest assured.

192c

Socrates: Is not endurance, accompanied by wisdom, good and noble?

Laches: Absolutely.

Socrates: What if it is accompanied by ignorance? In that case, on the contrary, is it not harmful and damaging?

Laches: Yes.

192d

Socrates: Now, will you say that something like this is noble when it is damaging and harmful?

Laches: No, Socrates, that would not be right.

Socrates: So you do not accept that endurance of this sort is courage, since it is not noble, and courage is noble.

Laches: That is true.

Socrates: So, based on your argument, wise endurance is courage.

Laches: So it seems.

192e

Socrates: Well, let us see. In what respect is it wise? Is it wise in all respects, significant and trivial? For instance, if someone endures in spending his money wisely, knowing that he will gain more from spending it, would you call this man courageous?

Laches: By Zeus, I would not.

193a

Socrates: What if someone is a physician, and his son, or someone else with a lung infection, is begging for drink or food, and he is unyielding and endures in his refusal?

Laches: No, that is not courage either, not at all.

Socrates: And in war, what about a man who is prepared to fight, who calculates wisely, who knows that others will come to his aid, and that he is fighting against fewer troops, inferior to those on his side, whilst holding the better ground? Would you say that this man, who endures with this sort of wisdom, is more courageous than the man in the opposing army who is prepared to stand his ground and endure?

193b

Laches: The man on the opposite side seems more courageous to me, Socrates.

Socrates: And yet this man's endurance is more foolish than the other man's.

Laches: That's true.

Socrates: So you will also say that a man with knowledge of horsemanship, who endures in a cavalry battle, is less courageous than someone who does so without that knowledge.

Laches: I think so.

Socrates: And the one who endures, with knowledge of slinging or archery or any other skill, is less courageous.

193c

Laches: Certainly.

Socrates: And those who are prepared to go down into a well and dive, and who demonstrate endurance in this, or in another task like this, without being trained, will you say that they are more courageous than those who are trained?

Laches: Yes, Socrates, what else could anyone say?

Socrates: Nothing, if he actually thinks so.

Laches: Well then, I think so at any rate.

Socrates: And yet, Laches, such people are running risks and demonstrating endurance in a more foolish manner than those who perform the action with knowledge of the skill.

Laches: Apparently.

193d

Socrates: In our earlier discussion, did not foolish boldness and endurance prove to be shameful and harmful?

Laches: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And yet courage was agreed to be something noble.

Laches: Yes, that was agreed.

Socrates: But now, on the contrary, we are saying that this shameful behaviour, foolish endurance, is courage.

Laches: So it seems.

Socrates: Well, do you think we are talking sense?

Laches: By Zeus, Socrates, I do not.

193e

Socrates: So I presume, to use your phrase, Laches, you and I are not attuned to the Doric mode, for our deeds are not in concord with our words. In fact, if someone were listening to our discussion now, he might declare that in action we do, it seems, partake of courage, but in words I think he would say that we do not.

Laches: Very true.

Socrates: What about this? Do you think this is a good predicament for us to be in?

Laches: No, not at all.

Socrates: Well, do you want to accept our statement to this extent?

Laches: To what extent, and what statement do you mean?

Socrates: The statement that calls for endurance. So if you are willing, we too should stand our ground and endure in this search so that courage itself does not laugh at us, because we are not seeking it courageously if it turns out that endurance itself is courage after all.

194b

Laches: Socrates, I am prepared to persist even though I am unaccustomed to discussions of this sort. But in the light of what has been said, I am gripped by a thirst for victory, and I am truly annoyed that I find myself unable to express the concept I have. For although I seem to have a concept of what courage is, I do not know how it escaped me just now so that I cannot get my words together to state what it is.

Socrates: Well, my friend, the good huntsman should pursue his quarry and not give up.

Laches: Entirely so.

194c

Socrates: So, let us also invite Nicias here to the hunt. Do you agree? He may be more resourceful than we are.

Laches: I agree. Why wouldn't I?

Socrates: Come then, Nicias. If you have the power to do so, you should come to the aid of your friends, who are caught up in a storm of discourse and are perplexed. You surely see how perplexed we are, but if you say what you think courage is, you will free us from the perplexity and give certainty to your own concept by putting it into words.

194d

Nicias: Well, it has seemed to me, Socrates, for quite some time that you are not defining courage properly. For you are not referring to an excellent maxim, which I have heard you stating before.

Socrates: What maxim, Nicias?

Nicias: I have often heard you say that 'each of us is good wherein he is wise and bad wherein he is foolish'.

Socrates: Well, by Zeus, Nicias. That is true.

Nicias: In that case, if the brave man is indeed good, it is obvious that he is wise.

Socrates: Did you hear that, Laches?

Laches: I did, but I do not really understand what he is saying.

Socrates: Well, I think I understand, and the man seems to me to be saying that courage is a kind of wisdom.

Laches: What kind of wisdom, Socrates?

Socrates: Why not put this question to the man himself?

Laches: I am.

194e

Socrates: Come on then, Nicias, tell him what sort of wisdom courage would be, according to your account. For I presume it is not the wisdom of flute-playing.

Nicias: Not at all.

Socrates: Nor indeed that of harp-playing.

Nicias: Of course not.

Socrates: But what is it then? Knowledge of what?

Laches: That certainly is the right way to question him, Socrates. He should say what he says it is.

195a

Nicias: I say, Laches, that it is the knowledge of what is to be feared and what is to be ventured, in war or in any other situation.

Laches: How strangely he speaks, Socrates.

Socrates: What have you in mind when you say this, Laches?

Laches: What? Wisdom is surely distinct from courage.

Socrates: Yet Nicias says otherwise.

Laches: Indeed he does, and talks nonsense in the process.

Socrates: Then let us instruct him rather than abusing him.

Nicias: Well, Socrates, I think Laches wishes to make out that I too am talking nonsense because he was shown up for doing that sort of thing himself a moment ago.

195b

Laches: Yes, indeed, Nicias, and I shall attempt to prove this at any rate, for you are talking nonsense. So, for instance, in the case of diseases, aren't the physicians the ones who know what is to be feared? Or do you think the courageous people know? Or do you call the physicians courageous?

Nicias: No, not at all.

195c

Laches: Nor the farmers either, I suppose, even though they surely know what is to be feared with regard to the cultivation of the earth. And all the other practitioners know what is to be feared and what is to be ventured in relation to their own areas of expertise. But that does not mean they are any more courageous.

Socrates: What do you think Laches is saying, Nicias? He does seem to have a point.

Nicias: He has a point alright, but it is not true.

Socrates: How so?

Nicias: Because he thinks physicians know something more about sick people than how to pronounce them healthy or ill. Yet this, surely, is the full extent of their knowledge. But, Laches, do you believe the physicians know if being healthy is to be feared by someone, more so than being ill? Or don't you think that it is better in many cases not to recover from an illness? Yes, tell me this. Do you maintain that it is better, in every case, to be alive? In many cases is it not preferable to be dead?

195d

Laches: I think so.

Nicias: And do you think the same things are to be feared by those who are better off dead as by those who are better off alive?

Laches: I do not.

Nicias: Well, do you attribute this knowledge to the physicians or to any other practitioner, apart from the man who knows what is to be feared and what is not – the man I call courageous?

Socrates: Do you understand what he is saying, Laches?

195e

Laches: I do. He is saying the soothsayers are the brave ones, for who else would know who is better off alive rather than dead? And what about yourself, Nicias? Do you admit to being a soothsayer, or are you neither a soothsayer nor courageous either?

Nicias: What is this? Do you yourself think that it is the role of the soothsayer to know what is to be feared and ventured?

Laches: I do, otherwise whose role could it be?

Nicias: It is much more the role of the people I am speaking of, best of men, since the soothsayer need only recognise the signs of what will happen, whether someone will die or be ill or lose his property, whether he will be victorious or suffer defeat in war, or in any other contest. But it is no more a role for the soothsayer than for anyone else at all to decide which of these is best for someone to suffer or not suffer.

196a

Laches: Well, Socrates, I do not understand from this what he wants to say, for he is explaining that he does not refer to the soothsayer or the physician, or anyone else, as a man of courage unless he is saying that it is some god. In fact, as I see it, Nicias is not willing to admit honestly that he is talking nonsense. Instead, he twists this way and that in an effort to conceal his own perplexity. Yet you and I could have performed similar twists a moment ago if we had wanted to avoid seeming to contradict ourselves. Well, if our arguments were being presented in a court of law, there might be some reason to do this, but now, at a gathering of this sort, why would someone adorn himself vainly with empty words?

196c

Socrates: There is no reason to do so, Laches, but let us see. Perhaps Nicias thinks he has a point and is not saying all this just for the sake of talking. So let us find out from him, with greater clarity, what exactly he has in mind, and if it turns out that he has a point we shall go along with it, and if not we shall teach him.

Laches: Well then, Socrates, if you want to find out, go ahead and find out. Perhaps I have found out enough.

Socrates: That will not stop me. Indeed, the enquiry will be on my behalf and yours.

Laches: Very well then.

Socrates: So tell me, Nicias, or rather tell us both, since Laches and myself are sharing the conversation: are you saying that courage is knowledge of what is to be feared and what is to be ventured?

Nicias: I am.

Socrates: And this knowledge does not belong to everyone, since neither the physician nor the soothsayer will know this, nor will they be courageous unless they acquire this particular knowledge. Isn't this what you were saying?

Nicias: It was indeed.

196d

Socrates: So in fact, as the saying goes, 'not every sow would know this', nor would she be courageous.

Nicias: I think not.

Socrates: Obviously, Nicias, you do not believe that even the Crommyonian sow was courageous. And I am not saying this in jest. No, I think it is necessary that someone who maintains this should not accept that any wild beast is courageous, or agree that any wild animal is wise in this way, and thus maintain that

a lion, a leopard or some boar knows what very few humans know, because it's so hard to know. But someone who proposes that courage is what you are proposing it is must maintain that a lion, a stag, a bull or a monkey are, by nature, equally courageous.

196e

Laches: By the gods, Socrates, you are putting that well. And you should answer this truthfully for us, Nicias. Are you saying that these wild animals, who everyone agrees are courageous, are wiser than we are, or would you dare to go against everyone and not even call them courageous?

Nicias: Laches, I do not call wild animals courageous, or anything else that does not fear what is to be feared because it lacks intelligence. Instead, I call them fearless or stupid. Do you think I even call all the children, who fear nothing because they lack intelligence, courageous? No, to my mind fearlessness and courage are not the same. I am of the opinion that courage and foresight belong to very few, while rashness, daring and fearlessness, devoid of foresight, belong to a vast number of men, women, children and wild beasts. So actions that you and most others call courageous, I call rash, but the wise actions I am referring to are courageous.

197b

Laches: Do you see, Socrates, how nicely this fellow adorns himself with words? Or so he thinks. Yet he is trying to deprive those who are universally agreed to be courageous of their due respect.

Nicias: Laches, I am not referring to you, so take heart. Indeed, I declare that you are wise, and Lamachus⁶ too, if you are actually courageous, and so are a host of other Athenians.

197c

Laches: I could respond to that but I shall say nothing, so that you cannot accuse me of being, in truth, an abusive Aexonian.

197d

Socrates: Do not speak, Laches. In fact, you seem to be unaware that he has acquired this wisdom from our mutual friend, Damon, and Damon is a constant associate of Prodicus, who is reputed to be the very best of the sophists at making verbal distinctions of this kind.

Laches: Yes, indeed, Socrates, it is more appropriate for a sophist to engage in such subtleties than a man whom the city chooses as her leader.

197e

Socrates: Blessed man, it is surely appropriate that those who provide leadership in matters of the greatest importance should partake of wisdom to the greatest extent. Yet I think Nicias merits questioning as to his point of view when he uses this word courage.

Laches: Well, question him yourself, Socrates.

Socrates: That is what I am about to do, best of men. However, you should not assume that I will release you from your shared role in the argument, so pay attention and consider whatever is said, along with me.

Laches: So be it, if it seems necessary.

198a

Socrates: So it does. And you, Nicias, should address us again from the beginning. You know, don't you, that at the beginning of the discussion we were considering courage on the basis that it was a part of excellence?

Nicias: Certainly.

Socrates: Did you not also give this answer: that it is a part, and there are other parts too, and when taken all together they are called excellence?

Nicias: Of course.

Socrates: Now, do you speak of these parts as I do? As well as courage, I call sound-mindedness, justice, and the like parts of excellence. Don't you?

198b

Nicias: Entirely so.

Socrates: Stop there, since we agree on these, and let us consider what is to be feared and what is to be ventured, in case you are of one view while we are of another. So we shall tell you what we think, and if you do not agree, you should instruct us. According to us, things that cause fear are to be feared, while those that do not are to be ventured. But it is not past evils that cause fear, or the present ones either, but only those that are anticipated, for fear is the anticipation of impending evil. Don't you agree with me, Laches?

198c

Laches: Very much so, Socrates.

Socrates: Well, Nicias, you have heard our views that, according to us, the impending evils are to be feared, while impending goods, or things that are not evil, are to be ventured. Is this the way you describe them, or is there another way?

Nicias: This way.

Socrates: And the knowledge of these you refer to as courage?

Nicias: Precisely.

Socrates: We should still consider whether we are all in agreement on a third issue.

Nicias: What issue is that?

198d

Socrates: I shall tell you. It seems to myself, and to this man, that in cases where there is knowledge of something, there is not one knowledge that knows how things happened in the past, another concerned with how they are happening at

present, and another dealing with how what has not yet happened will happen, and may best happen. No, it is the same knowledge. For example, in the case of past, present and future health, no other knowledge, apart from medicine, as one, superintends what is happening, what has happened, and how what is going to happen will unfold. And the same also holds for farming, in the case of what is produced from the earth. And when it comes to warfare, the two of you will of course bear witness to the fact that generalship, on the whole, best foresees the future, and it does not believe that it should be subservient even to the soothsayer in relation to the future. No, generalship should rule, as it has better knowledge of how military affairs are unfolding and will unfold. And so the law decrees that the soothsayer has no authority over the general. No, the general has authority over the soothsayer. Is this what we shall say, Laches?

198e

Laches: It is.

Socrates: What about this, Nicias? Do you agree with us, that in dealing with the same issues the same knowledge knows about the future, the present and the past?

Nicias: I do, yes. That is how it seems to me, Socrates.

199a

Socrates: Now, best of men, do you not also say that courage is knowledge of what is to be feared and ventured? Is this so?

Nicias: Yes.

Socrates: And it was accepted that what is to be feared and what is to be ventured are future goods and future evils?

Nicias: Entirely so.

Socrates: And the same knowledge is concerned with the same matters in the future, or at any other stage?

Nicias: This is the case.

199b

Socrates: In that case, courage is not only knowledge of what is to be feared and what is to be ventured. No, just like the other kinds of knowledge, it has knowledge not only of impending goods and evils, but also of those that are present, or past, or at any other stage.

Nicias: So it seems, anyway.

199c

Socrates: So, Nicias, the answer you gave us constitutes part of courage, one third at best, even though we asked you what courage was as a whole. And indeed it now seems, based upon your argument, that courage is not just knowledge of what is to be feared and ventured, but according to your present argument, courage would more or less be knowledge of all good and evil in all cases. May we make this adjustment? What do you say, Nicias?

Nicias: I think so, Socrates.

199d

Socrates: Now, do you think, blessed man, someone like this would be lacking in any excellence, if he actually knew good in its entirety, and fully understood how it arises, will arise, and has arisen, and understood evil in like manner? And do you think this man would be deficient in sound-mindedness or justice or holiness when he alone is equipped to pay careful attention to what is to be feared, or not, in relation to gods or humans, and to ensure good outcomes by knowing how to deal with them aright?

Nicias: I think you have a point, Socrates.

199e

Socrates: In that case, Nicias, what you are now describing would not be a part of excellence, but excellence in its entirety.

Nicias: So it seems.

Socrates: Yet we said that courage is one of the parts of excellence.

Nicias: Yes, we said that.

Socrates: But what is now being described does not appear to be a part.

Nicias: It seems not.

200a

Socrates: In that case, Nicias, we have not discovered what courage is.

Nicias: Apparently we have not.

Laches: But Nicias, my friend, I assumed you were going to make the discovery when you were so contemptuous of my responses to Socrates. Yes, I really had great hopes that you would discover it, using this wisdom you acquired from Damon.

Nicias: That is nice, Laches. You still do not think it is a problem that you yourself, earlier, proved to know nothing about courage. No, as long as I am shown up as someone else like that, that is what you focus on, and it seems to make no difference to you that you know as little as I do about issues on which a man of any reputation should be knowledgeable. Now, you seem to me to be acting in a truly human fashion by focussing not upon yourself, but on other people. As for myself, I think the issues we have discussed have now been adequately dealt with, and if any of them have not been covered in a satisfactory manner I shall correct them in due course with the help of Damon, whom you somehow think you can ridicule without ever having set eyes on Damon himself, and with the help of others too. And once I am certain about them, I shall also teach you. I shall not begrudge you that, for you seem to me to be very much in need of instruction.

200c

Laches: Well, Nicias, you are wise, but nevertheless I am advising Lysimachus here, and Melesias, to bid yourself and myself farewell when it comes to the education of the young men. But as I said at the outset, they should hold on to this man, Socrates, and if my own sons had been at the right age I would have done the very same thing.

200d

Nicias: There I agree with you. If Socrates is prepared to look after the young men, do not search for anyone else. Indeed, I would gladly entrust Niceratus to this man if he were willing. But the fact is, every time I raise the matter with him he recommends someone else, and is unwilling to do it himself. But, Lysimachus, see if Socrates will be more responsive to you.

Lysimachus: It is only right that he should, Nicias, since I would be willing to do a great deal for him that I would be reluctant to do for very many others. So what do you say, Socrates? Will you respond and share in our eagerness that the boys become as good as they possibly can?

200e

Socrates: The fact is, Lysimachus, that it would be a terrible thing to be reluctant to share in the eagerness that anyone become as good as possible. Now, if in the course of our earlier discussions I had turned out to be knowledgeable and these two gentlemen had not, it would have been right to invite me, in particular, to take on this role, but as it is we have all ended up in a similar state of perplexity. So why would anyone prefer one of us over the other? So, in my opinion, none of us should be chosen. But since that is how matters stand, think about the piece of advice I am about to give you. For I declare, gentlemen – and my statement is not to be made public – that all of us ought to search together for the best teacher we can find, for ourselves first and foremost, for we really need one, and then for the young men too, sparing neither money nor anything

else. But I do not recommend that we remain in our present condition. And if anyone should laugh at us because we still see merit in frequenting teachers at our time of life, I think we should quote Homer who says that ‘modesty is not a good companion for a man in need’. And so we, paying no heed to what anyone may say, should jointly undertake the care of our own selves and of the young men.

201b

Lysimachus: Socrates, I am delighted at what you are saying, and insofar as I am the oldest man here, I am also the one who is most eager to learn, along with the young ones. So I want you to do something for me. Come to my home tomorrow at daybreak, without fail, so that we may deliberate on these very issues. But let us break up our gathering for the moment.

Socrates: I shall do as you ask, Lysimachus, and come to you tomorrow, God willing.

NOTES

1. Nicias and Laches were Athenian generals during the Peloponnesian War. Nicias was also a politician, best known for negotiating the 'Peace of Nicias', a temporary armistice between Athens and Sparta.
2. Damon of Athens was a noted musicologist and teacher of Pericles. Republic 400b ff and Alcibiades I 118c.
3. Delium was the site of an Athenian defeat by the Boeotians during the Peloponnesian War. Socrates' bravery during this battle is referred to in a number of Plato's dialogues.
4. Iliad v.229-238.
5. This was a legendary wild pig which wreaked havoc on the village of Crommyon (between Corinth and Megara) before it was slain by Theseus.
6. Lamachus was an Athenian general during the Peloponnesian War. He, together with Nicias and Alcibiades, commanded the Sicilian Expedition.
7. Someone from the Athenian deme of Aexone. They had a reputation for being abusive speakers.
8. Odyssey xvii.347.

Laws

NOMOI

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

ATHENIAN STRANGER

CLINIAS of Cnossus, Crete

MEGILLUS of Sparta

scene: ascending from Cnossus to the cave of Zeus

BOOK I

624a

Athenian: Well, my friends, was it a god or some human who was responsible for establishing your laws?

Clinias: A god, stranger. Yes, that is the fairest answer. Among ourselves in Crete it was Zeus, while among the Spartans, where this man comes from, I think they say it was Apollo. Is this so?

Megillus: Yes.

624b

Athenian: Don't you say, as Homer does, that Minos used to make regular visits every ninth year to be with his father, Zeus, and he set down the laws for your cities based upon his pronouncements?¹

Clinias: Yes, that is what we say. And, indeed, we also say that his brother, Rhadamanthus – you have heard the name I am sure – was exceedingly just. And we Cretans would maintain that he won this reputation, deservedly, based on the way he dealt with the legal issues of the time.

625a

Athenian: A good reputation indeed, and most befitting to a son of Zeus. And since yourself and this man have been brought up under such lawful customs as these, I presume that spending time now, listening to one another speak about civic affairs and laws, would not be an unpleasant prospect as we proceed on our journey. The road from Cnossus to the cave and sanctuary of

Zeus is quite a long one I am told, but there are it seems resting places, shaded from this extreme heat, along the way, among the tall trees. At our age it would be appropriate that we take a rest often among them, relax and exchange stories with one another, and thus complete the entire journey with ease.

625c

Clinias: Yes indeed, my friend, and as we proceed there are tall cypress trees of wonderful beauty in the groves, and there are meadows too in which we may take a rest and converse.

Athenian: You are right to suggest this.

Clinias: Yes, indeed, and we will say so all the more when we see them. So let us proceed, and may good fortune attend us.

Athenian: So be it. But tell me this. Why is it that the law regulates your common meals, physical exercise, and the nature of your military equipment?

625d

Clinias: Well, my friend, I think that our arrangements are easy for anyone to understand. Indeed, the entire Cretan countryside is not, as you see, flat like Thessaly, and so they make more use of horses; while we are runners, since our territory is rugged and more suited to exercise that involves running. In a country like this then, it is necessary to wear light armour rather than trying to run in heavy armour, and the lightness of bows and arrows seems to fit in with this. All these arrangements equip us for war, and, as I see it, the lawmaker had this in mind when he made all the regulations. And that is probably why he got people together for common meals, seeing that all those who are ever on military campaign necessarily have meals together for their own protection, for the duration, because of the circumstances. Here, I believe, he is demeaning of the stupidity of the broad mass of people who do not understand that there is always constant warfare going on against all of the cities

throughout one's life. Now, if it is necessary when there is a war on to have meals together for purposes of protection, and for some rulers and some subjects to act in turn as their guards, the same thing should be done in time of peace. For what most of the people call peace is so in name only, while in fact all the cities are, by nature, always involved in undeclared warfare against all other cities. And if you look at it in this way, you will surely find that the Cretan lawgiver had an eye to warfare when he instituted all these regulations of ours, be they public or private. And he gave us the task of protecting the laws based on these principles, because nothing else at all, no possessions or pursuits, are of any use unless we prevail in war, since all the goods of the defeated city go to the victorious one.

626b

Athenian: Well, stranger, when it comes to the thorough understanding of Cretan law, you seem to me to have been very well trained. But explain something to me more clearly. The definition you gave of a well-governed city seems to me to be saying that it should be organised and managed so that it is victorious in war against other cities. Is this so?

Clinias: Yes, indeed. And I believe that this man here agrees with this.

Megillus: Heavens! How could any Spartan say otherwise?

Athenian: Now, although this is true of a city in relation to another city, does something different apply to a village in relation to another village?

Clinias: Not at all.

Athenian: Is it the same?

Clinias: Yes.

626c

Athenian: What about one household in the village in relation to another, and one man against another? Is it the same?

Clinias: The same.

Athenian: And what about the man himself, in relation to himself? Should he think of himself as an enemy? Or what do we say in this case?

626d

Clinias: O Athenian stranger! I am not prepared to refer to you as a mere inhabitant of Attica, for I think you really deserve to be named after the goddess,² since you have correctly brought the argument back to its source and made it clearer. As a result, you will easily discover that we were right to say just now that all are enemies to all, at the level of the community or of the individual, and each individual is an enemy of himself.

Athenian: That is surprising! What do you mean?

626e

Clinias: That is to say he himself, winning a victory over himself, my friend, is the first and the best of all victories, while he himself, being defeated by himself, is the worst and most shameful defeat of all. Indeed, these statements are indicating that there is a war going on in each of us, against our own selves.

627a

Athenian: Well, let us turn the argument around again. For since each one of us is both better than himself and worse than himself, should we maintain that the same holds for a household, a village and a city, or not?

Clinias: Are you asking about being better than itself and worse than itself?

Athenian: Yes.

Clinias: And you are right to ask, for this certainly is the case, very much so, especially in cities. For in any cities, where the superior people win a victory over the majority, who are inferior, the city may rightly be said to be better than itself, and the city may quite justly be praised for such a victory. And the opposite applies under the opposite circumstances.

627b

Athenian: Let us set aside the possibility that the inferior might somehow be better than the superior, since that would involve a longer argument. But as I now understand you, you are saying that unjust citizens, of the same stock, born in the same city, will sometimes get together in large numbers and forcibly enslave just citizens who are fewer in number. Whenever they prevail, the city itself may rightly be said to be worse than itself and bad, and whenever they are defeated, the city itself may be said to be better than itself and good.

627c

Clinias: What you are describing is most unusual, stranger. Nevertheless, we have to agree that this is most necessarily so.

Athenian: Hold there. Let us consider this once more. Many brothers may presumably be born, sons of one father and one mother, and it would not of course be a surprise if more of them turned out to be unjust, and less of them to be just.

Clinias: It would not.

627d

Athenian: And it would not be appropriate for you and me to pursue the point that the entire household, and the family, would be referred to as worse than itself if the evildoers were victorious, and as better than itself if they were defeated. For what we are now considering, in relation to the argument of the majority, is not concerned with the appropriateness or inappropriateness of verbal expressions, but with laws, and the precise nature of correctness and freedom from error in them.

Clinias: Very true, my friend.

Megillus: Yes, I agree. This has been very well expressed so far.

Athenian: Then let us look at the following question too. The brothers that were spoken of just now would, presumably, have a judge?

Clinias: Yes, indeed.

627e

Athenian: Now, which of these two would be superior, a judge who destroyed the bad people among them, and directed the better people to rule over themselves, or one who made the good people rule, while allowing the inferior types to live on as their willing subjects? And there is perhaps a third judge we should mention in terms of excellence – if such a person exists – one who takes a single quarrelling family in hand, does not destroy anyone, but reconciles them for the future, and would be able to ensure that they are on friendly terms with one another by giving them laws.

628a

Clinias: This sort of judge, who is also a lawgiver, would be far superior.

Athenian: And yet, he would not be enacting laws for them with a view to war. The very opposite would be the case.

Clinias: That is true.

Athenian: What about the one who brings the city together in harmony? Does he order the life of the city with a view to external warfare, rather than looking out for warfare that arises from time to time within the city, which is called faction? And this is something that no one ever wants in his own city, and when it arises he wants it to be eliminated as quickly as possible.

628b

Clinias: He will look out for faction, of course.

628c

Athenian: What if faction were to come to a peaceful end because some people had been destroyed while others had been victorious? Would that be preferable to reconciliation of the faction and having to turn their thoughts then to external enemies, in friendship and peace with one another?

Clinias: In the case of their own city, the reconciliation is what everyone would prefer.

Athenian: Doesn't the same apply to the lawgiver?

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: And wouldn't every lawgiver institute all the regulations for the sake of what is best?

Clinias: How could he do otherwise?

628d

Athenian: And what is best is neither warfare nor faction. It would be terrible if we needed these. What is best is peace and a friendly disposition towards one another at the same time. What is more, it seems the city itself, winning a victory over itself, is not to be counted among the best outcomes, but among those that are necessary. It is as if someone were to think that a sick body, which had undergone medical purgation, was then in the best possible condition and did not pay any attention to a body that did not need any treatment at all. In like manner, no one would ever become a true statesman by focusing exclusively and primarily upon external warfare as a means of ensuring the happiness of the city and of the individual. Nor would he ever be a lawgiver in the strict sense of the word, unless he instituted laws relating to warfare for the sake of peace, rather than instituting laws relating to peace for the sake of warfare.

628e

Clinias: It appears somehow that this argument of yours, my friend, has been formulated correctly. And, yet, I wonder if the regulations here, and those in Sparta too, have not been enacted, in all seriousness, for the sake of warfare.

Athenian: Perhaps so. Yet we should not do battle with them aggressively, but question them gently about the issues, since we are most serious about all this, and so are they. Follow along with my argument then. At any rate, let us introduce Tyrtaeus,³ an Athenian by birth, who later became a citizen of Sparta. He, of all men, was particularly interested in these matters, and he said that *I would make no mention of a man or take account of him, even if he were the wealthiest of men even if he possessed goods aplenty...* and here he lists almost all of them *...unless he turned out to be consistently excellent in warfare.* I presume that you have heard these poems too, while I am sure that our friend here has had his fill of them.

629b

Megillus: I certainly have.

Clinias: Yes, indeed, and they have reached us here too, imported from Sparta.

629c

Athenian: Come on, then. Let us question this poet together in some such manner as this: “O Tyrtaeus, you are surely the most divine of poets, for you seem to us to be wise and good indeed, because you have sung the praises of those who excel in war, and you have excelled in doing so. Now, I myself, and this man, and Clinias of Cnossus, are already in full agreement with you on this matter, or so we think, but we would like to know for certain whether or not we are both talking about the same people. So tell us, do you think, for certain, as we do, that there are two kinds of warfare? Or what do you think?” In response to this, I believe, even a far lesser man than Tyrtaeus would state the truth, that there are two, one which all of us call faction,

which is the most bitter of all kinds of warfare, as we ourselves said just now. And we shall all propose, I believe, that the other kind of warfare is what we engage in when quarrelling with other peoples externally, and this is much milder than internal faction.

Clinias: Of course.

629e

Athenian: “Come on then, which warfare were you praising? And which men did you praise so highly, or criticise? It seems it was the men involved in external warfare, for you say in your poems that you simply cannot stand the sort of men who shrink at the sight of blood-drenched slaughter, and will not grapple with the enemy at close quarters.” And after all this, shouldn’t we also say, “It seems, Tyrtaeus, that you lavish most praise on those who achieve fame in external warfare against foreigners.” I presume he would agree with this, and accept the point.

Clinias: Of course.

630a

Athenian: But although these men are good, we maintain that those who excel conspicuously in the greatest warfare are better by far. And we have a poet as witness to this too, Theognis,⁴ a citizen of Megara in Sicily, who says, “In a bitter contest, a faithful man is worth his weight in silver and gold, Cynrus.” We maintain then that this man turns out to be altogether better than that other man in more bitter warfare. He is better to much the same extent as justice, sound-mindedness and wisdom, combined with courage, are better than courage just by itself. For faith and soundness in the midst of faction would never arise in the absence of overall excellence. But in the external warfare that Tyrtaeus speaks of, there are vast numbers of mercenaries ready and willing to stand their ground and die fighting, almost all of whom turn out to be reckless, unjust, arrogant and devoid of intelligence, with

some few exceptions. Well, where will this present argument of ours finally lead? And what precise point is it trying to make by saying all this? Obviously it is this. The god-inspired lawgiver of this country, and any lawgiver who confers even a little benefit, always institutes laws while looking, above all, to nothing else except the very greatest excellence. This, according to Theognis, is “faithfulness in the midst of danger”, which may be called ‘perfect justice’. But what Tyrtaeus for his part has praised most – although it is noble, and has been appropriately glorified by the poet – should nevertheless, properly speaking, be placed fourth in terms of its status and the respect it commands.

630d

Clinias: My friend, we are relegating our own lawgiver to the lowest rank.

Athenian: No, my friend, we are not doing it to him. We are relegating ourselves whenever we believe that Lycurgus and Minos instituted all the regulations,⁵ here and in Sparta, mainly with a view to warfare.

Clinias: How should we have spoken of this?

Athenian: In a way that is true and just, I believe, since we are conversing on behalf of a divine personage. We should not say that he instituted laws with a view to a portion of excellence, and the most commonplace portion at that, but with a view to excellence in its entirety. And we should say that he sought to institute the laws kind by kind, but not the kinds proposed by those who institute laws nowadays. For at present each seeks to propose whatever kind he needs, so one person is concerned with inheritances and heiresses, another with assaults, others with countless other cases like these. But we maintain that the search for laws, when properly conducted, proceeds just as we have now begun. And I thoroughly admire your attempt to explain the laws, for beginning with excellence, and saying that

the lawgiver instituted the laws for the sake of this, is correct. But when you went on to maintain that he institutes laws by referring everything to a mere portion of excellence, and the smallest portion at that, I thought you were clearly mistaken, and that is why the latter part of our discussion was needed. Well then, what sort of distinction would I have liked to hear you making as you spoke? Would you like me to tell you?

Clinias: Yes, certainly.

631b

Athenian: You should have said: “Stranger, it is not for nothing that the laws of Crete are held in exceptionally high regard among all Greeks. They are correct laws that bring about happiness in those who use them, for they provide everything that is good. Now, goods are of two kinds – human and divine – and the human goods depend upon the divine. And if a city receives the greater it also acquires the lesser, but if it receives not the greater it is deprived of both. Of the lesser goods, health is the leader, beauty comes second, third comes strength in running and the other activities of the body, fourth comes wealth – not blind,⁶ but keen-sighted, provided it follows wisdom. Now, the first of the divine goods, and their leader, is wisdom; second is a sound-minded disposition of the soul, imbued with reason; and third, from the combination of these two with courage, comes justice; while courage itself is fourth. All of these have a natural priority over the human goods, and that indeed is how the lawgiver must rank them. After all this, the citizens must be told that the other civic regulations have these goods in view; the human look to the divine, and the divine all look together to their leader, reason. “In their connections through marriage, and afterwards in the birth of their children and their nurture, be they male or female, when they are young or when they get older and into old age, it is necessary to care for them by bestowing honour or dishonour

in the right way. And in all their interactions, in their pleasures, pains, desires and intense passions, they should be watched and supervised, and censure or praise should be bestowed in the right way, through the laws themselves. In anger too, and in fear, and amidst any tribulations that arise in their souls because of bad fortune – and the escape from such tribulations in good fortune – and amidst the effects that disease, war, poverty and their opposites have upon people when they occur, under all such circumstances, what is good and what is bad about the situation should be defined and taught in each case. “Besides this, it is necessary for the lawgiver to watch over the acquisition and disposition of property by the citizens, regardless of how they do it, and to oversee their joint ventures in furtherance of this, and the dissolution of these, be they voluntary or involuntary, noting the way in which they behave towards one another in each of these ventures, and which are just, and which are not. He should assign honours to those who are obedient to the laws, and impose legally prescribed penalties upon those who disobey them. When he reaches the end of the entire constitution, he would look to the manner in which the dead should be buried in each case, and what honours should be assigned to them. Having surveyed this, the one who instituted the laws will, over all these, appoint guardians, some who proceed through wisdom, some who work through true opinion, so that reason may bind them all together and declare that they are following sound-mindedness and justice, rather than wealth and ambition.” So, my friends, that is how I at least wanted, and still wish even now, to hear you describe how all these are present in the laws that are said to come from Zeus, or in the laws of Pythian Apollo, which Minos and Lycurgus instituted. And I also want you to explain how the order they have acquired is evident to someone experienced in the laws, either technically or practically, while it is not at all apparent to the rest of us.

632e

Clinias: Well, my friend, what should we say next?

Athenian: In my opinion we should go through this again from the beginning, starting, as we did at the outset, with activities conducive to courage, and then if you wish we shall go through another kind of excellence, and another one after that. Once we have described the first one, we should try to set this up as a model, and pass the journey nicely by discussing the others in the same way. Later, god willing, we shall demonstrate that what we have described just now has excellence in its entirety in view.

633a

Megillus: That is a good suggestion. Let us try to put our friend here, who praises Zeus, to the test first.

Athenian: I shall also try to test yourself and myself, since the argument is common to us all. So tell me, do we maintain that the common meals and physical training were devised by the lawgiver for the purposes of warfare?

Megillus: Yes.

Athenian: And what comes third and fourth? For it may perhaps be necessary, in the case of the rest of excellence, to rank the parts, or whatever they should be called, in this way, as long as our meaning is clear.

633b

Megillus: Well I myself, and anyone from Sparta, would say that he devised hunting third.

Athenian: We should try to say what comes fourth or fifth if we can.

Megillus: In fourth place, I would still try to argue, lies the endurance of pain, which is so important to us both in our boxing matches and in the robberies we devise, in which there is always a lot of physical violence. Then there is our so-called

‘secret service’,⁷ which involves a lot of pain, but teaches endurance wonderfully. They go without shoes in winter, sleeping on the ground, wandering through the entire countryside by day and by night, looking after themselves without any attendants. Our naked games too are formidable tests of endurance, battling against the raging heat of summer. And there are so many other examples that someone who tried to recite them all would almost never stop.

633d

Athenian: Well said, Spartan stranger. But come now, what should we propose courage is? Is it simply, as you say, doing battle only against fears and pains, or is it set against desires and pleasures too, and against certain formidable corrupting flatteries, that soften the hearts even of those who think they are above this sort of thing?

Megillus: Yes, that is what I think. It is set against them all.

Athenian: Well, if we recall the earlier arguments, this man here spoke of a city that is worse than itself, and of such a man too. Is this so, stranger from Cnossus?

Clinias: Very much so.

633e

Athenian: And are we now saying that the man who is worse than the pains is bad, or is the man who is worse than the pleasures bad too?

Clinias: In my opinion, the one who is worse than the pleasures is more so. Indeed, we all say, presumably, that someone who is ruled by pleasures is worse than himself, shamefully so, rather than someone who is ruled by pains.

634a

Athenian: Now, surely Zeus’ lawgiver and the Pythian one did not institute a crippled courage capable of resisting only the things on its left-hand side, but unable to resist the allurements

and flatteries on its right? Or can it resist on both sides?

Clinias: On both sides, I would say.

Athenian: Shall we say then, once more, what formal activities of both our cities involve tasting the pleasures rather than avoiding them, just as the other activities did not avoid pains but immersed people in them, and used honour to compel or persuade people to rule over the pains? Where then, in the laws, is the same arrangement in relation to pleasures? Let us say what this arrangement of yours is that makes the same people courageous, in like manner, in the face of pains and in the face of pleasures, winning victories over what they should, and never coming off worst against their own closest and harshest enemies.

634b

Megillus: Well, stranger, although I was able to describe, as I did, many laws that are set against pains, I would probably not be so well provided with significant or obvious instances if I had to speak about pleasures. But I might come up with some minor instances.

Clinias: Nor could I myself point to an obvious instance of this sort in the laws of Crete.

634c

Athenian: Best of strangers, that is no surprise. But if any one of us is going to censure anything about each other's own domestic laws because he wishes to discern the truth, and what is best too, we should accept one another's censures submissively, and not make difficulties.

Clinias: Rightly said, Athenian stranger. We should heed that.

Athenian: Yes, Clinias. It would not be appropriate for men of our age to make difficulties.

Clinias: Indeed, it would not.

634d

Athenian: Whether or not someone is right to criticise the constitution of Crete or Sparta is another matter. However, when it comes to the views expressed by most people, I am probably better able to state them than either of you. If your laws have indeed been arranged properly, one of the best laws would be that no young person may conduct an enquiry as to which laws are worthy and which are not, but all must declare together, with one voice, from a single mouth, that all is well with what the gods have ordained. If anyone says otherwise, he is not given a hearing at all. Yet if any old person has some issue on his mind about your laws, he presents arguments of this sort to someone in authority, someone of his own age, with no young person present.

Clinias: What you are saying is quite correct, stranger. And although you are far removed in time from whoever instituted them, it seems you have now guessed his thinking on the matter quite well, like a prophet, and you really are speaking the truth.

634e

Athenian: Well, there are no young people among us just now. So if the lawgiver permits us, on account of our old age, to discuss these matters just by ourselves, we would be doing no great harm, would we?

Clinias: This is so. And do not hold yourself back from criticising our laws, since recognising something that is not good is not disrespectful. In fact, a remedy can be a consequence of this, provided that what is said is received without resentment, in a good spirit.

635a

Athenian: Very well, but I shall not speak critically of your laws just yet, not until I have investigated them to the best of my ability, and am more certain about them. Instead, I shall tell you of my difficulties. As far as we can discover, your lawgiver is the

only one, among Greeks or non-Greeks, who gave directions to refrain from the greatest pleasures and amusements, and not to taste of them at all. Yet when it came to pains and fears, as we explained earlier, he believed that if someone flees from these from his earliest years, in the end whenever he meets with unavoidable hardships, fears and pains, he is going to flee from people who are trained and practised in these, and he will be enslaved by them. I am of the view then that the same lawgiver should have thought the very same thing about pleasures, saying to himself, "If our citizens grow up from their very childhood with no experience of the greatest pleasures, and become totally unpractised in enduring in the face of pleasures, and in resisting the urge to perform shameful acts, their weakness of spirit when it comes to pleasures will place them in the same predicament as those who are overcome by fears. They will be enslaved, in a different and even more shameful way, by people who are able to practise endurance in the face of pleasures, and who have mastered the realm of pleasure, people who are sometimes thoroughly bad. The state of their own soul will be partly slave, partly free, and they will not be worthy of being hailed as courageous and free without reservation." So think about whether anything that has been said is of any particular relevance.

635e

Clinias: Well, although the argument somehow seems to us to make sense, it might well be both naïve and foolish to be persuaded, so quickly and easily, about matters of such significance.

Athenian: But if we turn to the next topic we proposed to discuss after courage, which was sound-mindedness, then, Clinias and my friend from Sparta, we should ask a question. What characteristic difference shall we find between these systems of government and systems that are managed in a more

random manner? In the case of courage, the difference related to warfare. Where does it lie in the case of sound-mindedness?

Megillus: Hardly an easy question, but it does seem that the common meals and physical training have been well devised to promote both virtues.

636a

Athenian: It does, of course, seem hard, strangers, for anything relating to constitutions to be as uncontroversial in practice as it is in theory. Indeed, it is probably like the human body, for which it is not possible to prescribe a single activity for a single body, which would not turn out to be harmful to our bodies in some respects, but beneficial in other respects. So too these physical exercises and common meals, although they benefit the cities in lots of other ways, give rise to the problem of faction, as the young people of Miletus, Boeotia and Thurii demonstrate. What is more, this practice seems to have corrupted an ancient law that also accords with nature, concerning the sexual pleasures not just of humans, but also of animals. And your cities might be held primarily responsible for these, along with any other cities that place most emphasis upon physical training. And whether such matters are taken lightly or seriously, we should note that when the female and male natures combine for procreation, the associated pleasure seems to have been bestowed naturally. But combining male with male, or female with female, seems contrary to nature, and the daring of those who first did this seems to have arisen from uncontrolled desire. And, indeed, we all accuse the Cretans of making up the story about Ganymede.⁸ Since their laws are believed to have come from Zeus, they added this story about Zeus so that they could still enjoy this harvest of pleasure while following their god. But let us bid farewell to the story. Yet, when human beings are considering laws, almost the entire enquiry is about pleasures and pains, either in the city, or in the

behaviour of individuals. For pleasure and pain are two springs sent forth by nature. Drawing from the right one at the right time and in the right quantity leads to happiness in like manner for a city, an individual, or any living being. But whoever draws in ignorance and at the wrong time lives a life that is the very opposite.

636e

Megillus: What has been said, stranger, is in a sense all very well, and it leaves us speechless as to what to say in response. Nevertheless, I still think that the Spartan lawgiver was right to exhort us to flee from pleasures. As for the laws of Cnossus, our friend here can defend them if he wants to. But it seems to me that the regulations in Sparta relating to pleasure are the best in the world. For our law has cast out, from the entire country, the practice that is most inclined to plunge people into extremes of pleasure, arrogance and utter mindlessness. Neither in the countryside nor in the cities that are under Spartan control would you ever see drinking parties, and all the pleasures that are set in train with such force by whatever goes on there. There is no man among us who would not impose a severe penalty, there and then, upon any drunken reveller he came across, and the feast of Dionysus would not serve as an excuse to get him off. I saw this sort of thing once on the festival wagons in your country. And among our own colonies, in Tarentum, I saw the entire city drunk at a festival of Dionysus.⁹ There is nothing like this among us.

637c

Athenian: Dear Spartan stranger, everything of this sort is laudable where there is an inherent steadiness of character, but where this is let go, it all becomes quite stupid. Indeed, one of our people, in his defence, might perhaps take you to task by pointing to the looseness of your womenfolk. Yet in anything of this sort, in Tarentum, among ourselves or among yourselves, a single response seems to do away with the notion that the

behaviour is bad and improper. For everyone will say to a stranger who is amazed at seeing something that is unfamiliar among his own people, “Do not be surprised, stranger. This is the law among us, and perhaps your law about the same things is different.” But our present argument is not concerned with humanity in general, my dear friends, but with the badness and excellence of the lawgivers themselves. Indeed, we should still say more about drunkenness in general, for it is not a trivial matter, nor can an ordinary lawgiver understand it. And I am not speaking about wine, and partaking of it, or not partaking of it at all, but about drunkenness itself. Should we have recourse to it as the Scythians and Persians do – and the Carthaginians, Celts, Iberians, Thracians too, warrior races all – or should we avoid it totally, as you do in Sparta? The Scythians and Thracians, women as well as men, drink completely undiluted wine, pour it all over their garments, and regard this as a lovely, happy activity to engage in. The Persians also indulge in this with great relish, and in the other luxuries that you have banned, but they are more orderly than those other peoples.

637d

Megillus: But, my good man, once we take up arms we put all these people to flight.

Athenian: Best of men, do not say that. In fact, there have been lots of victories and routs that were unexplained, and there will be many more. Therefore, we should never say that victory or defeat in battle is a decisive indicator of whether practices are good or bad. This is a questionable criterion, since larger cities obviously defeat smaller ones in battle, and so we find the Syracusans enslaving the Locrians, who are reputed to have the best laws in that region, the Athenians enslave the Ceians, and you will find countless other examples of this sort. So let us try to persuade ourselves, by speaking of each practice in its own right, excluding victory and defeat from the argument for the

moment. We should simply say how a practice of one sort is good, while a practice of another sort is bad. But first, listen to me as I explain how we should investigate what is useful about these practices themselves, and what is not.

Megillus: How do you say it should be done?

638b

Athenian: It seems to me that those who set about discussing some practice, and propose to criticise it or praise it as soon as it is mentioned, are not proceeding in a proper manner at all. They are acting like someone who has just heard cheese being praised as good food, and immediately criticises it without enquiring as to the effect it has and the manner in which it is administered, by whom, accompanied by what, and to people in what condition. I think we are now doing the very same thing in these arguments, for at the mere mention of drunkenness, as soon as we heard the word, some of us criticised it there and then, while others praised it, most strangely in both cases. We each exalt our own position by recourse to witnesses and praise. Some of us claim we have made a decisive point because we produce so many witnesses, others because we can all see that those who refrain from drunkenness are victorious in battle, and this claim too is a matter of dispute between us. Now, if we are also going to go through each of the other legal regulations in this way, that would not seem reasonable to me. But I am willing to describe another approach, a necessary one in my view, in relation to this very practice, drunkenness. I shall try my best to demonstrate the correct method of investigating anything of this sort, since thousands upon thousands of people will enter the fray verbally on these issues, and argue against both your cities.

638e

Megillus: And, indeed, if we have a correct method of investigating such matters, there should be no reluctance to

hear it.

639a

Athenian: Then let us conduct our enquiry along the following lines. Suppose someone were to praise goat-rearing, and the animal itself as a good beast to own, while someone else, having seen goats grazing without a goatherd, and wreaking havoc on farm land, were to criticise them, and also disparage any other unruly animals he saw, or any that had bad minders, do we think that the censure of such a person could ever be sound on any issue at all?

Megillus: No, how could it be?

639b

Athenian: Would someone be useful to us in charge of a ship if he only had navigational knowledge, regardless of whether he suffered from seasickness or not? What would you say?

Megillus: He would not be useful at all if he had the skill, and the sickness you mentioned too.

Athenian: And what about someone in charge of an army? Would he be up to the task if he had military knowledge, despite being a coward in the face of dangers, seasick, and drunk with fear?

Megillus: How could he be?

Athenian: What if he did not have the skill, and was a coward too?

Megillus: Now, you are describing an utterly worthless fellow, who is not a ruler of men at all, but of some thoroughly effeminate types.

639c

Athenian: Consider any community of any sort which has a natural leader, and which is beneficent when that leader is present. What if someone were to praise or criticise this,

without ever having seen the community working properly together with its leader in place? What if he had only seen it without a ruler, or with bad rulers? Do we think that an observer of this sort, observing a community of this sort, would ever come up with any useful criticism or praise?

639d

Megillus: How could he when he has never seen, or been involved in, any communities like this when they are operating properly?

Athenian: Hold there. Although there are lots of communities, may we suggest that companions in drink and drinking parties constitute one such gathering?

Megillus: Very much so.

Athenian: Now, has anyone, so far, ever seen such a gathering operating properly? The two of you can easily answer that you have not seen this at all, since these are not the custom of your country, nor are they lawful. But I have come across lots of them in lots of places. And what is more I have made a sort of study of them, and I have hardly seen or heard of one that was properly conducted in its entirety. And even if a few minor details were somehow right, most of them were almost completely wide of the mark.

639e

Clinias: In what sense do you mean this, stranger? Explain this more clearly since we, as you have acknowledged, have no experience of such gatherings. And even if we came across them, we would probably not immediately recognise what was proper and improper about the way they were being conducted.

640a

Athenian: What you say is quite likely, but try to understand from this explanation of mine. You do understand, don't you, that in all gatherings and communities associated with any

activities whatsoever, it is always proper in each case that there be a leader?

Clinias: There must be.

640b

Athenian: And, indeed, we said just now that the leader of men in battle must be courageous.

Clinias: He must.

Athenian: Now, the courageous man is less troubled by fears than the cowards.

Clinias: This too must be so.

Athenian: And if there had been some contrivance for putting an utterly fearless and untroubled general in charge of an army, wouldn't we have done so, by any possible means?

Clinias: Definitely.

640c

Athenian: But at the moment we are not talking about a leader of an army of men in time of war, when enemies are set against enemies, but a leader of friends, communing with friends in a spirit of friendship in time of peace.

Clinias: Quite right.

Athenian: And yet, a gathering of this sort, since it will be accompanied by drunkenness, is not without trouble. Is this so?

Clinias: On the contrary, I think trouble is inevitable.

Athenian: So in the first place, don't they too need a leader?

Clinias: Of course, especially in this situation.

Athenian: Now, if possible, shouldn't we provide the kind of leader who is untroubled?

Clinias: Of course.

640d

Athenian: And, indeed, he should be intelligent in relation to social gatherings, since he becomes the guardian of their existing friendship, and responsible for ensuring that this increases because of the current gathering.

Clinias: Very true.

Athenian: Shouldn't a sober and wise ruler be set over those who are drunk, and not the opposite? For someone who was drunk, young, and not wise, would need a lot of good luck to avoid causing harm on a large scale.

Clinias: A lot of luck, indeed.

Athenian: Now, if someone were to criticise such gatherings, in cities where they are being properly conducted as best they could, because he finds fault with the activity itself, perhaps he might be justified in his criticism. But if someone reviles a practice when he has only seen it going wrong in every way possible, it is obvious, firstly, that he is unaware that this is not being properly conducted, and secondly, that any activity at all will look bad under circumstances where it is performed without a sober master or leader. Or don't you realise that when he is drunk, a ship's captain, or any leader of anything, overturns everything, be it a ship, a chariot, an army, or whatever he happens to be in charge of?

640e

Clinias: What you have said, stranger, is true in every respect. But tell us next what possible good would it do us if this regulation about drinking were to operate properly. For instance, we have just explained that if an army is led properly, the result is military victory for the troops, and that is no small benefit. There are other examples too, but what significant benefit would there be, to people or to a city, from a drinking party that is properly guided?

641a

Athenian: What about this? What great advantage would we say accrues to the city from a single child, or even a single group, being guided in the right way? Or having put the question in this way, would we reply that there might be some slight benefit to the city from a single instance? But if we ask generally what great benefit the city derives from the education of all its educated citizens, it is not difficult to reply that having been well educated they would prove to be good men, and, as such, their general behaviour would be noble, and, what is more, they would triumph over their enemies on the battlefield. Now, although education also brings victory, victory sometimes undoes the education, for many people, having become arrogant because of military victories, have then been filled up with countless other vices because of the arrogance. And although education has never proved counter-productive or Cadmeian,¹⁰ humanity has won many such Cadmeian victories, and will do so again.

641d

Clinias: You seem to us, my friend, to be saying that time spent drinking wine together, provided it is properly conducted, is a significant contribution to education.

Athenian: Why not?

Clinias: Well, could you now provide some justification that what you have said is true?

Athenian: Stranger, with so much dispute as to how these matters stand, it belongs to God to assert the truth with certainty. But if you want me to explain how it appears to me, I shan't begrudge you that, since we have now set about constructing arguments in relation to laws and constitutions.

641e

Clinias: That then is what we should try to understand, your opinion on the issues that are now in dispute.

Athenian: That is what we should do then. You should make an effort to understand the argument, while I attempt somehow or other to expound it. But listen to the following point first. The whole Greek world regards our city as fond of words and full of words, and Sparta as sparing of words, while Crete cultivates thoughtfulness rather than being full of words. Now, I am being careful not to give you the impression that I have a lot to say about something trivial, by enunciating a vast argument about the insignificant matter of drunkenness. But it would not be possible to consider the right treatment of this topic naturally, with sufficient clarity in our discussions, without considering correctness in music; and this would never be possible without considering education in its entirety; and all these involve very lengthy discussions. So what should we do? Let us see. What if we leave those matters for the moment and move on to some other argument relating to laws?

642b

Megillus: Athenian stranger, perhaps you do not know that our family is the local representative of your city in Sparta. Now, it is probably the case with all children that once they hear that they are the local representatives of some city, straight away, from their earliest years, a certain goodwill towards that city develops in each of them, as if towards a second fatherland, second only to his own city. And that is what has now happened to me. For when the Spartans were criticising or praising the Athenians for something, I would immediately hear the other children saying, “That city of yours, Megillus,” they would say, “has treated us badly” or “has treated us well”, and through entering the fray on your behalf, again and again, against those who found fault with your city, I developed unreserved goodwill for it. Even now your accent delights me. And when I hear so many people say that any Athenians who are good are good in a special way, I think they are speaking the complete truth, for Athenians are good by a divine portion, good by their own

nature without any compulsion, truly so, and not artificially so. Speak on then, as much as you like, and have no concerns on my account.

642d

Clinias: And, indeed, stranger, once you have heard my account too, and have accepted it, you may speak on boldly and say as much as you wish. Now, you may have heard that Epimenides, that divine man, was born in this country. He was a relative of ours, and ten years before the Persian War he went to Athens, to your people, to comply with an oracle of the god.¹¹ He performed some sacrifices that the god had ordained, and what is more, since the Athenians lived in fear of the Persian expeditionary force, he told them, “They will not arrive for another ten years, and when they get here they will depart without achieving anything they had hoped for, having suffered more harm than they inflicted.” That is when our ancestors formed a bond of hospitality with yours, and I myself and my family have been well disposed towards your people ever since.

643a

Athenian: Well then, it seems that you are both ready to play your part and listen. As for myself, although I am ready and willing, the capacity may be lacking as this is not at all easy, but I must make the effort nevertheless. In the first place then, to develop the argument, we should define what precisely education is, and what power it has. For we maintain that the argument we have taken in hand should proceed along the path of education, until it reaches God.

Clinias: Yes, certainly. Let us do that, if it pleases you.

Athenian: Well, what is education? What should we say it is? Let me answer that, and you should decide if what I say is to your liking.

Clinias: Proceed.

643b

Athenian: What I say is this. I maintain that a man who is to be good at anything at all should practise just that activity from his earliest years, both as a game and seriously, using the particular tools that are appropriate to the activity. Take, for example, a man who is to be a good farmer or house-builder. The builder should play at building toy houses, and the other man should play at farming, and whoever is rearing them should provide each of them with little tools, imitations of the real ones. And, indeed, any of the essential subjects should be learned in advance. And so a carpenter should learn to measure and calculate, a military type should learn horse-riding for sport, or do something else like that, and we should endeavour to turn the pleasures and desires of the children, through games, to where they should ultimately be directed. We are saying then that the essence of education is the correct upbringing which most effectively draws the soul of the child, as he plays, to an intense love of the activity in which he will need to be perfect, in terms of its excellence, when he becomes a man. Now, as promised, let us see if what I have said so far is to your liking.

Clinias: Of course it is.

643d

Athenian: Unless perhaps our description of education still lacks definition. For we are now criticising and praising various upbringings, and we say that one of us has been educated while another is uneducated, and sometimes we are speaking about people who have been thoroughly well educated in certain trades, or in merchant shipping and other such occupations. But in our present argument we would not, it seems, regard any of these as education. We mean education directed to excellence from earliest childhood, which produces an eager desire to become a perfect citizen who knows how to rule and be ruled justly. This argument of ours, having distinguished this particular upbringing from the others, would in my view wish

to refer to this alone as education. And it would say that an upbringing whose aim is money, or some sort of strength, or even another kind of wisdom devoid of reason and justice, is base and slavish, and totally unworthy of being called education. But let us not quarrel with one another over names. Let us hold to the argument we have just agreed upon: that those who have been properly educated usually become good, and education should be shown no disrespect anywhere, since it is foremost among the fairest acquisitions that the best men have. And if it ever goes astray, it is possible to set it right, and this is what everyone should do, unceasingly, to the very best of his ability throughout his entire life.

Clinias: That is right. We agree with what you are saying.

644a

Athenian: And, indeed, we agreed some time ago that the good people are those with the ability to rule over themselves, while the bad are those who cannot do so.

Clinias: What you are saying is correct.

644c

Athenian: Well, let us look at this again, more clearly this time, and say what precisely we mean. And if you allow me, I shall explain this to you by means of an image, if I can.

Clinias: Proceed.

Athenian: May we assume that each of us is, himself, one?

Clinias: Yes.

Athenian: But we each possess, in ourselves, two opposed advisers, devoid of intelligence, which we call pleasure and pain.

Clinias: This is so.

644d

Athenian: Besides these two, there are opinions relating to the future. These go by the general name of ‘expectations’. But to be specific, the expectation prior to pain is called fear, while the expectation prior to pleasure is called confidence. Then there is reasoning about all these as to which is better and which is worse, and when reasoning becomes a doctrine that is common to the city, it is given the name ‘law’.

Clinias: I am following you somehow, but with difficulty. However, assume that I am following you, and tell me what comes next.

Megillus: Yes, I feel the same way.

Athenian: Then let us think about these matters as follows: let us consider each of us living creatures as a puppet of the gods, constructed as their plaything, or for some serious purpose. This we do not understand, but we do know that these emotions within us, like cords or strings, are drawing us, and because they are opposites they are pulling against one another, towards opposite activities, and here lies the boundary line between excellence and evil. And the argument declares that we should each always follow the lead of one of these pulls, and never forsake that one at all, but pull against the other cords. The cord to follow is the golden and sacred guidance of reasoning, called the common law of the city. The other cords are hard and of iron, and they occur in endless varieties, but this one is soft because it is made of gold. We should co-operate then with the exalted guidance of the law. For reasoning, although it is noble, is also gentle and not violent, so its guidance needs our support, so that the golden race within us may triumph over the others. And so the story about excellence, the story about us being puppets, would be saved, and the meaning of being better than oneself and worse than oneself would somehow become clearer. It would also be more obvious that the individual should take to heart the true account

concerning these various pulls, follow this, and live accordingly; while the city, having adopted an argument either from some god, or from this person who understands these matters, should pass a law to govern its dealings with itself and other cities. In this way too, the distinction between badness and excellence might be clearer to us, and once this has become more evident, perhaps we shall have a better perspective on education and the other practices. And in particular, although the pastime of wine drinking might seem to be commonplace, and an odd topic to discuss at such great length, it may well turn out to be worthy of a lengthy discourse after all.

Clinias: Well said. So let us proceed with whatever this discussion requires.

645d

Athenian: Come on, then. If we bring drunkenness to bear upon this puppet of ours, what sort of effect will it have?

Clinias: Why do you ask? What's the purpose of this enquiry?

Athenian: Nothing in particular, I am just asking what sort of thing generally happens when this interacts with that. But I shall try to explain what I mean more clearly. Does the consumption of wine make pleasures and pains, anger and passion, more intense?

Clinias: Much more intense.

645e

Athenian: But what about sense perception, memory, opinions and intelligence? Do these become more intense in the same way? Or do they totally forsake a person once someone becomes intensely drunk?

Clinias: Yes, they forsake him completely.

646a

Athenian: Doesn't his soul revert to the same state it was in when he was a child?

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: And that is when he would be least in control of himself?

Clinias: Least.

Athenian: And don't we say that a person like this is thoroughly bad?

Clinias: Thoroughly so.

Athenian: So it is not just the old man, it seems, who experiences a 'second childhood', but the drunkard too.

Clinias: Excellent, stranger. Well said.

Athenian: In that case, is there any argument that will attempt to persuade us that this is a practice we should indulge in, and not one we should flee from with all the strength we can muster?

646b

Clinias: It seems that there is. At any rate, you maintain that there is such an argument, and you were ready to state it a moment ago.

Athenian: Yes, that is true, you remember. And I am now ready to do so, since you have both declared your willingness and eagerness to listen.

Clinias: We shall listen. We simply must, if only because of your surprising and odd assertion that a person should ever plunge himself, willingly, into an utterly depraved state.

Athenian: Are you referring to the state of his soul? Is that what you mean?

Clinias: Yes.

646c

Athenian: What about this, stranger? Would we be surprised if someone ever, of his own free will, got into a physical state of emaciation, ugliness and weakness?

Clinias: We would of course.

Athenian: Now, do we imagine that people, who themselves go along to medical centres to be treated with drugs, do not realise that shortly afterwards, and for many days, their body will be in such a state that if they had to live like that for the rest of their lives, they could not bear it? And we know, don't we, that people who go to the gymnasium and do hard exercises become weak at first.

Clinias: Yes, we know all this.

646d

Athenian: And don't we also know that we engage in all these willingly, for the sake of the benefits that follow from them?

Clinias: Quite so.

Athenian: Shouldn't we also think about any other practices in the same way?

Clinias: Yes, indeed.

Athenian: In that case, we should also think of the pastime of wine drinking in the same way, if it may, indeed, properly be thought of as one of these practices.

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: Now, if it turns out that this practice is beneficial to us, just as beneficial as the practices associated with the body, it would still win out over physical exercise, because that is accompanied by pain in the beginning, while wine drinking is not.

646e

Clinias: You are right about that, but I would be surprised if we were able to discover any such benefit in this.

Athenian: Then this, it seems, is just what we should now attempt to explain. So, tell me. Can we discern two kinds of fear that are almost direct opposites?

Clinias: What kind of fears?

Athenian: As follows. Presumably we are afraid of evils when we expect them to occur?

Clinias: Yes.

647a

Athenian: And we are often afraid of opinion when we believe that people will form a bad opinion about us, for doing or saying something that is not noble. And we ourselves, and I believe everyone else too, refer to this fear as shame.

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: These are the two fears I meant. The second of them stands in opposition to pains, and to the other fears, and also to the most numerous and intense pleasures.

Clinias: Correct.

647b

Athenian: Now, doesn't the lawgiver, and anyone else who is of any use, show the utmost respect for this fear and refer to it as 'reverence'? The boldness that is opposed to this he calls 'irreverence', and he regards this as the greatest possible evil, both for a private individual and for a community.

Clinias: Correct.

Athenian: Doesn't this fear save us in many other ways, all of them important? And doesn't this, more so than anything else, ensure victory in war, and our safety in every case? For there are two things that ensure victory: boldness in the face of

enemies, and fear before our friends of the evil associated with shame.

Clinias: Quite so.

647c

Athenian: So each of us should become fearless, and fearful, for the reasons we have distinguished in either case.

Clinias: Certainly.

Athenian: And, indeed, when we wish to make each person fearless in the face of many fears, we ensure this by drawing him into fear, legally.

Clinias: Apparently so.

Athenian: And what about our attempts to make someone fearful, in a manner that conforms to justice? Shouldn't we make him victorious in the battle against his own pleasures, by pitting him against shamelessness, and training him to oppose it? A person should become perfect in courage by doing battle against the cowardice in himself and defeating it. And, indeed, anyone who has no experience or training in such struggles would not attain even half of his own potential in terms of excellence. But in the case of sound-mindedness, can he ever attain perfection without putting up a strong fight against the many pleasures and desires that turn him to shamelessness and injustice, and prevailing against them with the aid of reason, action and skill, both in play and seriously, rather than being devoid of experience of this sort of thing?

647e

Clinias: That would be quite unlikely.

Athenian: What about this? Is there a drug for fear, that some god has given to humanity, such that the more someone is willing to drink of it, the more he regards himself, with every drop he drinks, as doomed to misfortune? He gets afraid of

everything, present and future alike, and in the end even the most courageous man there is gets consumed with fear. But once he has slept off the potion and is rid of its effects, he always becomes himself once again.

648a

Clinias: Is there a potion like this, stranger? Can we claim that such a thing exists?

Athenian: There is no such thing. But if it had existed somewhere, would it have been of any use to the lawgiver in promoting courage? We might well have had a discussion with him about this, somewhat as follows: “Come, lawgiver, whether you are proposing laws for Crete or for any other people, would you like first to have a test at your disposal to determine the courage and cowardice of the citizens?”

Clinias: Every legislator would obviously say, “Yes”.

648c

Athenian: What about this? Would you like a test that is safe, and without significant risks, or the opposite?

Clinias: The test should be safe. Everyone will agree on this.

Athenian: And would you use the test by inducing these fears, and testing the people under these circumstances, so as to compel them to become fearless by exhorting, warning and rewarding them? Would you dishonour anyone who did not obey you and thus become the sort of person you directed them to be? And wouldn't you let someone go without a penalty if he had completed his training well and courageously, but impose some penalty if he had done badly? Or would you not use the potion at all, even though you had nothing else to say against it?

Clinias: How could he decline to use it, stranger?

648d

Athenian: In any case, my friend, in comparison with what is done nowadays, this training would be wonderfully easy to

apply to one person, a few, or to as many people as anyone might ever wish. And what if someone preferred to be alone, in solitude, ashamed at the prospect of being seen until he believed he was in good condition? Suppose he exercised against the fears in this way, equipped only with the potion instead of lots and lots of practices? Wouldn't he be acting correctly? And so too would someone else who, trusting that he himself was properly equipped by nature and by practice, had no reluctance about engaging in the exercise, along with numerous drinking companions, and demonstrating his capacity to transcend this, and retain control in the face of the inevitable disturbance brought on by the potion. And so, because of his excellence, he would not succumb to any serious disgraceful conduct at all, nor would he behave differently. And before the last draught arrived, he would quit the scene, for fear of the defeat that the potion finally inflicts upon everyone.

648e

Clinias: Yes, stranger. In fact a person like this, acting like this, would be demonstrating sound-mindedness.

Athenian: Then, let us speak once more to the lawgiver as follows. "So be it, lawgiver. Although no god has actually given a fear-inducing drug like this to humanity, nor have we devised one ourselves – and I am excluding sorcerers – is there nevertheless a potion to induce excessive courage at the wrong time, where it is not needed?" What do we say?

649a

Clinias: I presume he will reply that there is such a potion, and he will say that it is wine.

Athenian: Doesn't this have the very opposite effect to the one we described just now? Initially it immediately makes the person who drinks it more cheerful than he was before, and the more of it he imbibes the more he is filled with high hopes and with power too, or so he thinks. And in the end, doesn't a

person like this behave like a wise man, and abound in utter frankness, freedom, and complete fearlessness, so that he says anything at all without hesitation, and acts in just the same way? I think everyone would agree with us on all this.

Clinias: Of course.

649b

Athenian: Let us remind ourselves then of the following. We declared that there are two things in our souls that should be cultivated: one so that we may be as confident as possible, and the other, its opposite, so that we may be as fearful as possible.

Clinias: This one we call reverence, I believe.

Athenian: Well remembered. And since courage and fearlessness should be practised in situations of fear, we have to decide whether their opposite would need to be cultivated under opposite circumstances.

Clinias: Well, that is likely to be the case.

Athenian: So, there are situations in which we naturally become exceptionally bold and daring. And these are the situations in which we should practise being as free as we possibly can from shamelessness and audacity, and fearful of ever daring to say, feel, or do anything shameful.

Clinias: So it seems.

649d

Athenian: Now, we are like this, aren't we, in anger, passion, insolence, ignorance, avarice, cowardice? And we may also include wealth, beauty, strength, and anything else that makes us drunk with pleasure and drives us out of our minds. And when it comes firstly to providing an inexpensive and harmless test of these, and for practising with them too, can we think of any pleasure more measured than a playful trial in wine drinking, provided it is conducted carefully? Let us consider

this. Should we test for an intractable and wild soul, the source of countless injustices, by entering into business dealings with the person, and run all the associated risks, or is it safer to get together at a festival of Dionysus? Or should we carry out a trial of a soul that is dominated by sexual desires by turning our own daughters, sons and wives over to that person, thus putting our nearest and dearest in danger, in order to see the condition of his soul? And, indeed, you could give countless examples, and still not show just how superior this safe and secure method of observing people through play actually is. And, indeed, I do not think the Cretans or any other peoples at all will dispute the fact that in these matters, this is a fair way of testing one another. And in terms of its low cost, safety and speed, it is superior to other tests.

650b

Clinias: Well, that is true.

Athenian: This then, the recognition of the natures and dispositions of souls, would be one of the most useful things for that skill which involves caring for them. And this skill, according to us, is I presume statesmanship. Is this so?

Clinias: Entirely so.

BOOK II

652a

Athenian: It seems, then, that the next question we need to consider is whether discerning one another's natures is the only good that comes from the correct use of wine parties, or whether they involve some important benefit that deserves to be taken very seriously. Well, what do we say? The argument, it seems, wishes to indicate that such a benefit is involved, but we should hear how and in what sense, paying close attention in case we get tangled up in the argument.

Clinias: Speak on.

653a

Athenian: Well then, I wish to recall once more what exactly we say right education is, in our view. For my guess now is that the salvation of education lies in this activity being organised in the right way.

Clinias: That is a bold claim.

653b

Athenian: Well, I am saying that the first, primitive sensation in children is pleasure and pain, and it is in these that excellence and vice first come to the soul. As for understanding, and confident true opinions, fortunate is the man to whom they come even in old age, and perfect is the person who has acquired these, and all the goods that are in them. And I call education the excellence that comes to children first, when pleasure, affection, pain and hate are engendered in the right way, in the souls of those who are not yet able to understand the reason. And when they do come to understand, they will concur with reason, and accept that they have become accustomed to acting in the correct manner because the habits of their childhood are so fitting. Now, this total concurrence is excellence, but there is a part of this that may be isolated in the argument and may be referred to as education, and in my opinion it would be right to do so. This part is the correct upbringing in relation to pleasure and pain, so as to hate what one should hate, from the very beginning right until the end, and love what one should love. If our argument were to separate this off and refer to it as education, we would in my opinion be naming it correctly.

Clinias: Yes, indeed, stranger. What you said earlier about education, and what you are saying now, sounds right to us.

653d

Athenian: Good. Now, although this correct training in pleasures and pains constitutes education, it slackens and diminishes to a considerable extent over the course of one's life, and the gods, taking pity on the natural hardship suffered by the human race, have instituted festival days as respites from our labours. And they have provided the Muses, and Apollo their leader, and Dionysus too, as our festival companions to regulate the festivals. And they provided sustenance there in the company of the gods. There is an argument that is repeated constantly nowadays, and we should see whether or not it is true, and accords with nature. It maintains that the young, all of them, are more or less incapable of keeping their bodies or their mouths quiet. Their constant endeavour is to move and make sounds, leaping and jumping, dancing with delight and playing around, and making all sorts of noises. Now, the other animals have no awareness of the kinds of order or disorder in their various movements, order that we call rhythm and harmony. But to us humans, who as we said were given the gods as our companions in dance, these very gods have given us an awareness of rhythm and harmony, accompanied by pleasure. By this awareness they move us and act as our chorus leaders, connecting us to one another with songs and dances. And they gave the chorus its name 'chorus' because of its natural charm.¹² First, then, do we accept this, and may we propose that education is, initially, through the Muses and Apollo? Or what should we say?

Clinias: Just that.

^{653e}

Athenian: So, for us, the uneducated person will be someone who has not participated in the chorus, and we should propose that the educated person has participated enough.

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: Now, a choral performance involves dancing and singing combined together.

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: So the person who has been well educated would be capable of singing and dancing well.

Clinias: So it seems.

654a

Athenian: Let us look at what exactly it is that we are saying now.

Clinias: What are you referring to?

Athenian: We say that 'he sings well' or 'he dances well', but should we add 'provided that what he sings is good and what he dances is good'. Or should we not add this?

Clinias: We should add this.

654b

Athenian: What about someone who regards what is good as good, and what is base as base, and makes use of them accordingly? Will such a person, in our view, be better educated in choral performance and music when he is consistently able to be faithful enough, physically and verbally, to his concept of what is proper, but takes no delight in anything good, and has no aversion to whatever is not? Would he be better educated than someone who was not really able, verbally or physically, to successfully accomplish anything good, or to conceive of it mentally, but is right when it comes to pleasure and pain, because he embraces whatever is good, and detests whatever is not?

Clinias: These two cases, stranger, are vastly different in terms of education.

654c

Athenian: Well then, if the three of us recognise what is good in relation to singing and dancing, we shall also know correctly who has been educated and who is uneducated. But if we do not recognise this, we would never be able to recognise clearly whether a guardian of education exists, and where it is. Isn't this so?

Clinias: It is so, indeed.

Athenian: So what we have to track down next, like hounds following a trail, is what is good bearing, melody, song and dance. But if these escape us and get away, vain would be our subsequent argument about correct education, either of Greek or of non-Greek.

Clinias: Yes.

654d

Athenian: So be it. What exactly then is good bearing and melody? What should we say? Come on then. Consider a courageous soul in difficult circumstances, and a cowardly soul under the very same circumstances. Will their bearing and their utterances turn out to be much the same?

Clinias: No, how could they when their very complexions differ?

654e

Athenian: Well said, my friend. But bearing and melody are present in music, which is concerned with rhythm and harmony, and so we may rightly speak of good rhythm and harmony in melody and bearing, but it is not right to use the analogous term 'good colour', as the choral teachers do. And yet, it is right to speak this way about the bearing and the melody of the coward and of the brave, and in the case of the brave these may correctly be referred to as good, and in the case of the cowards as base. Indeed then, to avoid an excessively lengthy speech, let's just say that altogether the bearings and

melodies associated with excellence itself, or some image of this, are good, while those associated with badness are bad. This applies to excellence and badness of soul or body.

Clinias: You are right to propose this, and for now our response is that this is how things are.

655c

Athenian: There is a further question. Do all of us take a similar delight in all choral performances, or is this far from being the case?

Clinias: Far from it, totally.

Athenian: Well then, what precisely is it that has sent us astray? Is it that what is good is not the same for all of us, or is it the same but does not seem to be the same? For I presume no one will ever say that choral performances of badness are better than those of excellence, or that he himself delights in the bearing that belongs to degeneracy while others prefer a Muse of the opposite sort. And yet most people say that the ability of music to provide pleasure to souls is the correct standard to judge it by. But this is unacceptable, and it is irreverent in the extreme even to say so. But what sends us astray is, more likely, something else.

Clinias: What?

655d

Athenian: Since choral performances involve imitations of characteristics arising in activities and situations of all sorts, each of the performers goes through the process using habit and imitation. Now, in cases where anything that is said, sung or performed accords with their character, by nature, by habit or by both, they are delighted, and cannot help but praise these performances and pronounce them good. But in cases where the performances go against their nature, character or some habit, they are unable to take any delight in them or to praise

them, so they pronounce them bad. Those whose nature is correct but whose habit is not, or those whose habit is correct but whose nature is not, are people who praise what does not please them. For they declare that each of these performances is pleasant but degenerate, and in the presence of others whom they regard as wise, they are ashamed to adopt bodily movements of the sort that feature in these performances, and ashamed also to sing songs of this sort and imply that they seriously approve of them. But, in private, they enjoy all this.

Clinias: You are quite right.

656a

Athenian: Now, does any harm come to someone who takes delight in bearing or melodies that are degenerate, or do any benefits come to those who take pleasure in the opposites of these?

Clinias: Quite likely.

656b

Athenian: Likely? Is he not, necessarily, in the same predicament as someone who keeps company with bad people of degenerate behaviour, and is delighted rather than repelled? He censures them, half joking, barely dreaming of just how vile this is. Then, of course, this happy man inevitably becomes like whatever company he delights in, even though he would be ashamed to be heard praising it. And, indeed, what greater good or evil could befall us than a totally inevitable process of this sort: a process of becoming like the company we keep? Can we say?

Clinias: I do not think there is one.

656c

Athenian: Now, where laws dealing with education about music in general, and entertainment, are established in the right way, or will be so in future, do we think the poets will be allowed in

their poetry to adhere to whatever rhythm, melody or utterance pleases the poet himself and teach this to the children of citizens who have such good laws, and to the young people in the choruses, regardless of the effect this has in terms of excellence or vice?

Clinias: No, that does not make sense. How could it?

656d

Athenian: And yet, nowadays, this is what is permitted, more or less, in all cities except in Egypt.

Clinias: Tell us then. What laws about such matters have been put in place in Egypt?

Athenian: It is an amazing story to hear. For the very argument that we are now stating was, it seems, recognised by them long ago, the argument that the young people in the cities should practise good bearing and good melody in familiar actions. They codified all the rules, indicating what they are and what they are like, and they displayed these in their temples. They did not allow either painters or anyone else who represents bearing and that sort of thing to innovate or contrive contrary to these, either in these areas or in music generally, except along traditional lines. Nor do they allow this today. And you will find, if you take a look, that the ten-thousand-year-old paintings and sculptures there – and they are literally ten thousand years old – are neither more beautiful nor less so than what is being produced today, because the same skill is being applied.

Clinias: Amazing.

656e

Athenian: Yes indeed, it is a triumph of legislation and statesmanship, but you will find problems there in other areas. But in the case of music this is the truth, and it is worthy of consideration. It was possible to be firm about such matters, and enact laws encouraging melodies that possess a natural

correctness. This would be a task for a god or some divine man, and in fact there in Egypt, they say that the melodies that have been preserved for such a lengthy period of time are actually compositions of Isis.¹³ So, as I said, if someone is able to grasp the correctness of these in any way at all, he should be bold enough to arrange them into a legal framework, since the yearning, driven by pleasure and pain, to indulge continually in new music does not really possess any great power to corrupt the sacred choral performance merely by referring to it as outdated. In Egypt, at any rate, it seems to have had no such corrupting influence at all – quite the opposite in fact.

Clinias: Yes, that appears to be how matters stand, based on what you are now saying.

657b

Athenian: In that case, may we be so bold as to describe the correct use of music and entertainment with choral performances somewhat as follows? We are delighted whenever we think we are doing well, and conversely whenever we are delighted we think we are doing well. Isn't this so?

Clinias: It is so, indeed.

Athenian: And indeed, in a situation like this where we are delighted, we are unable to come to rest.

Clinias: True.

657d

Athenian: Now, aren't our young folk ready and willing to perform in the chorus themselves, while we, their elders, think it more appropriate to spend our time watching them, delighting in their play and festive celebrations. Indeed, our own liveliness is forsaking us now, and because we yearn for this and cherish it, we set up contests for those who are able, as best they can, to rouse us through memory into youthfulness.

Clinias: Very true.

Athenian: So, we should not presume that what is commonly said nowadays about people who celebrate festivals is completely unfounded. It is said that whoever does the best job of cheering us up and delighting us should be regarded as the wisest, and judged to be the winner. In fact, since we are allowed to enjoy ourselves on such occasions, whoever brings most delight to the most people should be honoured most, and as I said just now he should carry off the victory prizes. So, consider what has been said. Isn't it right, and wouldn't this be the right course of action if it were to happen like this?

658a

Clinias: Perhaps.

Athenian: But, blessed man, let us not judge such an issue in haste. Let us rather take it part by part and consider it somewhat as follows. What if someone, sometime, were to set up a contest in some very simple way, without even defining whether it was a contest in gymnastics, music or horse-riding. Suppose he were to bring everyone in the city together, set up some victory prizes, and proclaim that anyone who wishes may come along and compete in a contest that is concerned only with pleasure. Whoever provides most entertainment to the spectators, without any restriction on how he does so, and who is better than everyone else at doing just this, and is judged to be the most pleasing competitor of all, will win. What do you think would come of a proclamation like this?

Clinias: In what sense?

658b

Athenian: It is likely, I suppose, that someone would present an epic poem, just like Homer; someone else a harp song or a tragedy or a comedy; and I would not be surprised if someone were to imagine that he really should be victorious because he put on a puppet show. So when people like this, and thousands of others too, enter the contest, can we say who deserves to

win?

Clinias: What a strange question. Indeed, who could ever answer you knowledgeably until he had heard each of the contestants, and listened to them himself?

Athenian: Well then, would you like me to give you this equally strange response?

Clinias: Indeed.

658c

Athenian: If very little children are to be the judges, they will opt for the puppet show, won't they?

Clinias: How could they do otherwise?

658d

Athenian: And if the bigger children decide, they will opt for the comedy, while educated women, young adolescents, and the vast majority of the population will probably choose a tragedy.

Clinias: Probably indeed.

Athenian: And perhaps old men like us would be most pleased at hearing a rhapsode reciting the *Iliad* or the *Odyssey* or something from Hesiod in a glorious manner, and would declare that he is the outright winner. So, who would be the rightful winner? This is the next question, isn't it?

Clinias: Yes.

658e

Athenian: Obviously, myself and yourselves will inevitably declare that whoever is chosen by people of our own age are the rightful winners, for of all the customs prevailing nowadays, in all of the cities, this seems best to us.

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: I agree with the majority viewpoint, to this extent at least: we should judge music by the pleasure it gives, but not to

any random person. Rather, music that gives pleasure to the best and most adequately educated people is almost the very finest music of all, especially the music that pleases the one person who excels in excellence and education. That's why we maintain that those who judge such matters need excellence. They have to possess understanding in general, and courage in particular. Nor should the true judge arrive at his judgement by learning from the audience, and be overpowered by the commotion of the crowd and his own lack of education. Nor again, even though he knows better, should he deliver his judgement without due care because he is a coward who lacks courage, thus speaking lies from the very same mouth out of which he invoked the gods when becoming a judge. For a judge, rightly speaking, does not sit as the pupil of the spectators, but rather as their teacher, and he opposes those who ply them with pleasure in a way that is neither appropriate nor correct. Indeed, the ancient Greek law allowed the judges to do this. But nowadays, in Sicily and Italy, the law hands the decision over to the majority of the spectators to decide the winner by a show of hands. This process corrupts the poets themselves, who then compose for the degenerate pleasure of their judges – the audience – thus corrupting the tastes of the actual audience members. Consequently, the audience itself is instructing the judges. For although they need to adopt more elevated pleasures by constantly hearing of behaviour that is superior to their own, the very opposite now happens to them, and they do it to themselves. What precisely do these various considerations in our argument wish to indicate to us? Think about it. Is it as follows?

Clinias: What?

659d

Athenian: It seems to me that the argument has come back full circle to the same place for the third or fourth time, and it says

that education consists in drawing or leading children towards the argument that is said by the law to be correct, and is confirmed as indeed correct by the experience of the most reasonable and mature people. The soul of the child should not get into the habit of being delighted or pained in a manner that is opposed to the law, and to those who obey it. The child's soul should follow along and be delighted and pained by the very same things as the elder folk. That is why we have songs, as we call them, which are really charms for souls, seriously intended to produce the sort of concord we are speaking of. But because the souls of the young are unable to bear the seriousness, we refer to these as entertainments and songs, and we act accordingly. It is just like the situation in which those who care for sick people with weak bodies try to give them the wholesome nourishment in some pleasant food and drink, and the unwholesome substances in unpleasant food and drink, so that they develop the good habit of being fond of one and detesting the other. In the same way, then, the good lawgiver will persuade, or, failing that, compel, the poetical type, in beautiful and encouraging language, to portray the bearing and the melodies of sound-minded, courageous and entirely good men, in his rhythms and melodies, by composing them correctly.

660a

Clinias: By Zeus, stranger, do you really think that that is how they compose in other cities these days? For as far as I can see, apart from ourselves and Sparta, I do not know of any cities doing what you are describing. Innovations are constantly being introduced in dance, and in the entire realm of music in general, and the changes are not based upon the law but on certain disordered pleasures, which are very far from being the same and unchanging, as they are in Egypt, according to your description. In fact, they are never the same.

660c

Athenian: That is excellent, Clinias. But if you think I am saying that what you are referring to is current practice, in that case then I would not be surprised if this happened because I am not expressing my thoughts clearly enough. I was describing what I would like to see happening in relation to music, and perhaps I gave you the impression that I was describing current practice. Now, it is not at all pleasant to criticise practices that are beyond remedy and well advanced in error, but sometimes it is necessary to do so. But since you agree with me on these matters, tell me, do you maintain that such practices are more prevalent among yourselves in Crete, and among the Spartans, than they are among other Greeks?

Clinias: Indeed.

660d

Athenian: And what if they were to be adopted by the other Greeks too? Should we maintain that these practices would be an improvement over the current situation?

Clinias: I expect it would make a big difference if the Spartan practices, or ours, or even the ones you prescribed just now, were adopted.

660e

Athenian: Come on then, let us agree on the immediate issues. In your cities, isn't this what is said on the entire subject of education and music? You compel the poets to say that the good man, being sound-minded and just, is also happy and blessed, and it makes no difference whether he is big and strong or small and weak, or whether he is rich or poor. In fact, even if he is richer than Cinyras or Midas,¹⁴ but is unjust, he is a wretched man living a miserable life. And your poet says – if he is right about this – “I would not even mention a man, or write his name down” unless he enacted and acquired everything that is said to be good, but did so in consort with justice. And, indeed, he shows a man like this “lunging at the enemy in close combat”,

while the unjust man doesn't even dare "to look upon the face of bloody slaughter"; nor does he outrun the "Thracian North Wind"; nor does he ever achieve anything else that is attributed to good people.¹⁵ Indeed, the things that are said to be good by most people are not being described correctly. For it is said that what is best is health, beauty is second, wealth third. And countless other goods are listed, including acuteness of sight and hearing, and keen perception of sense objects generally, and even becoming a tyrant and doing whatever you like. And the very pinnacle of all happiness is, they say, to acquire all these and become immortal, there and then. But I presume that you and I say that these are all excellent possessions for men who are just and holy, but to the unjust they are all of them thoroughly bad, beginning with health. And, indeed, we would say that seeing, hearing, perceiving and being alive at all, are evil in the extreme when someone is immortal forever, and possesses all these so-called goods in the absence of justice and total excellence, but the evil is less when such a person has a shorter span of life. Now, I think you will compel your own poets to say all that I say, and to educate your young people in this way by giving them rhythms and harmonies that accord with what is said. Is this so? Look at it this way, for I am saying in plain terms that the things that are said to be bad are good for the unjust people, but for the just people they are actually bad, while the good things really are good for the good people, but for the bad people they are bad. So, I repeat my question. Are the two of you and I in agreement, or not?

Clinias: Well, in some respects I think we are, but in other respects certainly not.

661e

Athenian: Suppose someone is possessed of health, wealth and endless tyrannical power – and for the two of you let me add exceptional strength and courage accompanied by immortality

– and that none of the other so-called evils befall him. But suppose that all he has within himself is injustice and arrogance. Perhaps you two are not convinced that someone who lives in this way is not really happy, but is obviously wretched?

Clinias: That's perfectly true.

662a

Athenian: So be it. What should I say to you next? Well, suppose someone is courageous and strong, handsome and wealthy, and does whatever he likes throughout his entire life. Don't you agree that if he is unjust and arrogant, he would necessarily be living in a shameful manner? Will you perhaps accept this word 'shamefully' at least?

Clinias: Yes, indeed.

Athenian: What about the word 'badly'?

Clinias: No, that's different.

Athenian: What about saying that he lives an unpleasant life that is not profitable to himself?

Clinias: How could we possibly agree with that?

662b

Athenian: How? Only if God, it seems, were to grant us some degree of concord, my friend, since for the moment at least there is a fair amount of discord among us. Yes, to me it appears that this is necessarily the case. It is even more obvious, my dear Clinias, than the fact that Crete is an island. And as a legislator, I would try to compel the poets, and everyone else in the city, to speak in this way. And I would impose perhaps the heaviest of penalties in cases where anyone in the land would say that there are some people who are degenerate and yet live pleasant lives, or who say that some things are profitable or advantageous while others are more just. And there is much

else I would persuade my citizens to say that contradicts the prevailing views of Crete and Sparta, it seems, and indeed of humanity in general. Come on then, best of men, by Zeus and Apollo. What if we were to ask these very gods who gave you your laws, “Is the most just life the most pleasant life? Or are there two lives, one that happens to be the most pleasant while the other is the most just?” If they were to declare that there are two, we would, if we were questioning them correctly, probably ask them again, “Which should we say are the happier people, those who live the most just life or those who live the most pleasant one?” Now, if they were to reply, “Those who live the most pleasant one”, their argument would be bizarre. But I don’t want to attribute such a response to the gods, but rather to our forefathers and lawgivers. So let my former question be put now to a forefather and lawgiver, and let him reply that whoever lives the most pleasant life is most blessed. I would then say, “Father, did you not want me to live as happily as possible? Yet you were always calling upon me unceasingly to live as justly as possible.” Now, whoever suggests this, be he a forefather or a lawgiver, would I think look most odd, and be at a loss about how to speak in a manner that is consistent with himself. But if, on the other hand, he declares that the most just life is happiest, anyone who hears this would, I believe, want to know what the law is praising in the just life. What does the just life contain that is good and noble, and superior to pleasure? Indeed, what good, apart from pleasure, could a just man have? Come on then, is fame and the acclaim of humanity and the gods pleasant, while the opposite applies to infamy? “Dear legislator,” we’ll say, “not at all”. If we neither do nor suffer injustice, is that unpleasant, even though it is good or noble? And is doing injustice pleasant, even though it is disgraceful and bad?

Clinias: No, how could this be so?

663a

Athenian: Now, although the argument does not separate pleasant, on the one hand, from just and good and noble, on the other, even if it does nothing else it still persuades a person to prefer to live a life that is holy and just. And for a legislator, the most disgraceful argument, directly opposed to his purposes, is the one that denies that this is the case. For no one would wish, willingly, to be persuaded to do anything that did not result in more pleasure than pain. But looking at things from afar produces a sort of dizziness in everyone, especially in young children, unless a lawgiver introduces a perspective that is the opposite of this; unless, having banished the darkness, he persuades people, somehow or other, by habits, praise or arguments, that their notions of justice and injustice are a play of shadows. When seen from the personal viewpoint of an unjust bad person who is opposed to justice, what's unjust appears pleasant and what's just appears most unpleasant. But from the perspective of the just person, the view of justice and injustice is the complete opposite in every way.

Clinias: Apparently so.

663c

Athenian: And which of these two judgements is more authoritative in terms of truth, the judgement of the worse soul or of the better one?

Clinias: It must be the judgement of the superior one, I presume.

Athenian: So, it must be the case that the unjust life is not only more shameful and degenerate than the just and holy life, but is in truth more unpleasant too.

Clinias: That, my friends, is quite likely, according to the present argument at least.

663d

Athenian: But even if what the argument has just established proved not to be the case, could a lawgiver, who was in any way useful, and who dared tell a lie to the young folk for some good purpose, ever tell a more profitable lie than this, or one with more power to make everyone do what's just in everything, willingly and without compulsion?

Clinias: Truth is noble and enduring, stranger, but it seems to be difficult to persuade people.

663e

Athenian: So be it. But it proved easy to persuade people of the myth about the Sidonian,¹⁶ incredible though it was, and the same applies to countless other stories.

Clinias: Of what sort?

Athenian: The story about the teeth being sown in the ground, and armed men growing from them.¹⁷ In fact, this is a great example for the lawgiver of persuading the souls of the young folk about anything at all, if one tries. Accordingly, in considering this, all he needs to do is find out what story would, once they believed it, lead to the greatest good for the city. And in this regard, he should seek out any means whatsoever whereby an entire community of this sort, and their discourse, would hold always to this theme with one and the same voice, as much as they can in their songs and in their stories. But if anything else occurs to anyone besides this way of looking at these matters, he should feel free to present a contrary argument.

664b

Clinias: No, I don't think either of us would be capable of presenting a counter argument, not on these matters at any rate.

Athenian: The next point is up to me then. So, I say that all the choruses, three in number, should sing to the still young and

tender souls of the children, stating all the noble principles we have recounted, and will, indeed, recount hereafter. Let's summarise them as follows. When we maintain that the most pleasant life, and the best life, are said by the gods to be the same, we shall be stating the very truth. And, at the same time, we shall persuade those who need persuading, more effectively than we would by saying anything else.

Clinias: We have to agree with what you are saying.

664c

Athenian: To begin with, it is only right that the children's chorus, dedicated to the Muses, should come in first to sing such songs, in all seriousness, before the entire city. Second should come the chorus of those who are under thirty, invoking Apollo Paean¹⁸ as witness of the truth of what is being said, and praying that he be gracious to the young, and convince them. A third chorus, consisting of those who are aged between thirty and sixty, should be next to sing. And that leaves the older group, who are no longer up to the task of singing, to present stories about the same characters through divine utterance.

Clinias: What is this third chorus you refer to, stranger? For we don't really understand clearly what you wish to say about these people.

Athenian: And yet most of the argument we have discussed so far was more or less concerned with these.

664e

Clinias: We don't understand yet. Please try to explain even more clearly.

Athenian: We said, if you recall, at the beginning of our discussions, that the nature of all young creatures is fiery, and unable to keep either the body or the voice quiet. The nature is constantly making disordered sounds and leaping about. We also said that none of the other creatures ever develops any

sense of order in body or voice. Human nature alone has this ability. The order associated with movement is called rhythm, and in the case of the human voice, the blending together of high- and low-pitched sounds is called harmony, and the two of these combined is called a choral performance. And we said that the gods, out of pity for us, gave us two fellow chorus members and chorus leaders, Apollo and the Muses, and in fact, you may recall, we said there was a third, Dionysus.

Clinias: How could we fail to remember?

665b

Athenian: Well, we have described the chorus of Apollo and of the Muses, so the third chorus, the remaining one, must be called the chorus of Dionysus.

Clinias: How so? Please explain. A chorus of old men, dedicated to Dionysus, sounds most unusual on first hearing. Are men who are over thirty or over fifty, or even as old as sixty, really going to be involved in a chorus dedicated to Dionysus?

665c

Athenian: That is perfectly true. An argument is needed here, I believe, to show that if this were to happen, it would be a reasonable development.

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: Now, are we in agreement about the previous matters?

Clinias: Specifically?

Athenian: About the need for every man and child, free born or slave, female or male, and indeed the whole city, to sing to themselves unceasingly the very charms we have described, changing them this way and that to provide all sorts of variety so that the singers develop an insatiable desire for the songs, and take pleasure in them.

Clinias: How could anyone disagree? Yes, this is what should be done.

665d

Athenian: Where then should the very best people in our city sing their magnificent and exalted songs so as to do the most good? These are the people who are more persuasive than anyone else in the city because of their age and level of understanding. Shall we be so foolish as to set this group aside when they are masters of the most exalted and beneficial songs?

Clinias: No, setting them aside is out of the question, based on what is now being said.

665e

Athenian: How shall we address this properly? See whether this will do.

Clinias: What then?

Athenian: Everyone I believe, as he gets older, becomes reluctant to sing songs, and takes less and less delight in doing so, and when compelled to do so is embarrassed. And the older and more sound-minded he becomes the more embarrassed he becomes. Isn't this so?

Clinias: It is so indeed.

Athenian: Wouldn't he be even more embarrassed to stand before people of all sorts, in the theatre, and sing? And if old people like this were compelled to sing, thin and fasting, just like chorus members training their voices for a competition, they would presumably take no pleasure in the task, and sing in embarrassment and without any enthusiasm?

Clinias: Yes, that's inevitable.

666a

Athenian: How, then, shall we encourage them to be enthusiastic about singing? Shouldn't we first pass a law that

children may not partake of wine at all until they are eighteen years old, explaining that fire must not be poured upon the fire that is already in their body and their soul before they turn their hand to life's labours. Here we are being cautious about the excitable disposition of the young. But after this they may partake of wine, in measure, until they are thirty, but drinking too much and getting drunk are totally prohibited to the young man. As he approaches forty years of age, he may enjoy the common meals and call upon the other gods, and he should invoke Dionysus in particular at the ritual for the older men, which is also their recreation. The god gave this to humanity as a healing draught to cure the crabbedness of old age so that we may grow young again, and our soul, by forgetting its dispiritedness, may become softer rather than harder in character, and become more malleable, just like iron when placed in the fire. First, wouldn't each of them, when this is the state of their soul, be willing to sing, or chant as we have often called it, more eagerly and with less embarrassment, not in front of lots of strangers, but before a select group of friends?

Clinias: Yes, much more.

666c

Athenian: So, as a means of getting them involved in our singing, this approach would not be entirely objectionable.

Clinias: No, not at all.

Athenian: What sort of sound will the men send forth? Or is it obvious that there must be some music appropriate to them?

Clinias: There must be.

Athenian: So what music would be appropriate to divine men? Would it be the music of the choruses?

Clinias: Well, stranger, we in Crete, and these Spartans, would be incapable of singing any other song besides the one we

learned and became familiar with in the choruses.

666e

Athenian: That is reasonable enough, since you have not actually attained the most exalted level of singing. Indeed, you have the civic constitution of a military camp but you have never settled in cities, and you keep your young people in a flock like a collection of grazing colts. None of you takes his own animal and drags it away from the grazing herd, as it gets wildly distressed. You don't appoint a private horse trainer to train him by rubbing him down and taming him and giving him everything that is appropriate for his upbringing so that he may be not just a good soldier, but able to manage a city or a town – someone who, as we said at the outset, is more of a warrior than Tyrtaeus' warriors, because he respects courage, always and everywhere, in private individuals and in entire cities, not as the foremost excellence, but as fourth in the scale of excellence.

Clinias: I don't know, stranger, whether or not you are somehow disparaging our lawgivers yet again.

667a

Athenian: My good man, if I am doing this at all, I am not doing it intentionally. But if you please, let's follow the argument wherever it may lead. For if we have music that is more exalted than the music of the choruses, or the popular theatres, we should try to make this available to these men, who we say are ashamed of that music and are eager for involvement with this most exalted music.

Clinias: Certainly.

667b

Athenian: Isn't it the case, first and foremost, with anything accompanied by some grace, that what is most significant is either the grace just by itself or else a certain correctness, or, thirdly, the benefit? For instance, food, drink and nutriment in general have an associated grace which we call pleasure. As for

their correctness and benefit, we consistently refer to the healthiness of whatever is consumed, and this very healthiness is what's most correct about them.

Clinias: Yes, certainly.

667c

Athenian: And there is indeed a grace that accompanies learning, namely pleasure, but that which produces its correctness – benefit, goodness and nobility – is the truth.

Clinias: Quite so.

667d

Athenian: What about skills that involve imitation and which produce likenesses? If they succeed in producing a likeness, may we rightly refer to the associated pleasure as grace?

Clinias: Yes.

Athenian: But the extent and the degree of equality with the original is what would, presumably, constitute the correctness of such likenesses, generally speaking, rather than the pleasure.

Clinias: That's right.

Athenian: In that case, using the criterion of pleasure, the only thing that we may judge correctly is something that is produced in order to provide neither benefit nor truth, nor likeness, nor indeed to do any harm – something that would exist only for the sake of that which accompanies these other factors, the grace which, when none of these other factors accompany it, is best called pleasure.

Clinias: You are referring only to harmless pleasure.

Athenian: Yes. And I am saying that this very pleasure is indeed amusement, whenever it does no harm or good worth mentioning seriously.

Clinias: Very true.

667e

Athenian: In that case, based on what we are now saying, we would maintain that it is entirely inappropriate to judge any imitation, or indeed its equality, by the criterion of pleasure or by untrue opinion. What is equal or symmetrical is not equal or symmetrical because it seems so to someone or because it does not please someone, but most of all because of the truth, and least of all because of any other consideration.

Clinias: Entirely so.

Athenian: Now, don't we maintain that all music is based upon likeness and imitation?

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: So whenever someone asserts that music is to be judged by the criterion of pleasure, this argument should be rejected, and if this music does somehow exist, we should not take it at all seriously in our search. We should seek rather the music that contains the likeness to the imitation of the beautiful.

Clinias: Very true.

668a

Athenian: And those seeking the most exalted song and music should not, it seems, seek what's pleasant but what's correct, for correctness of imitation, according to us, consists in reproducing the original, in quantity and in quality.

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: And, indeed, everyone would agree on this at least, that in the case of music everything that is produced involves imitation and representation. Wouldn't the composers, the audience and the actors all agree on this at any rate?

Clinias: Very much so.

668b

Athenian: Then anyone who is to avoid falling into error in a particular case should, it seems, recognise what precisely each of the compositions is. For if he does not recognise its being, what precisely the composition intends, and what it is a likeness of, he will hardly discern the correctness or error of the intention.

Clinias: Hardly indeed.

668c

Athenian: And would someone who does not recognise correctness ever be able to discern goodness or badness? But I am not expressing myself very clearly. Perhaps it would be clear if I put it as follows.

Clinias: How?

Athenian: There are, I suppose, thousands of imitations related to sight.

Clinias: Yes.

668d

Athenian: Well, what if someone was ignorant about the things that are being imitated in these cases, and did not know precisely what body each of them has? Could he ever recognise the correctness of the finished representation? For example, could he tell whether it has the correct number and placement of bodily parts, capturing how many there are, and how they are situated next to one another in their proper arrangement, including their colours and shapes, or whether all these have been fashioned in a confused manner? Do you think anyone could ever decide on this without knowing what precisely the creature being imitated actually is?

Clinias: How could he?

668e

Athenian: What if we were to recognise that what has been drawn or manufactured is a human being, and that the artist's

skill has captured all of its parts, colours and shapes? Is it necessarily the case that someone who recognises this also recognises, quite readily, whether the product is beautiful or is deficient in beauty in some particular way?

Clinias: Well, in that case, stranger, we would all in a sense recognise the beauties of the various animals.

669a

Athenian: What you are saying is most correct. So in the case of each image – in painting, in music, or in any form at all – mustn't anyone who is to be an intelligent judge have the following three abilities? Mustn't he be able firstly to recognise what it is, then how correctly it is rendered, and thirdly how well any of the images has been fashioned in language, melody and rhythm?

Clinias: So it seems, anyway.

669b

Athenian: Now, let us not omit mention of the difficulty that is involved in music. Indeed, since there is more talk about music than there is about the other images, it requires much more caution than any of the other images. For someone who falls into error here could do enormous harm by favouring degenerate behaviour, and the error is very hard to notice because our poets are lesser poets than the Muses themselves. For the Muses would never fall into error to such an extent as to compose words for men, and give them the colour or melody that belongs to women. Nor indeed would they frame a melody and bearing that belongs to free men, and harmonise it with rhythms that belong to slaves and to men devoid of freedom. Nor would they decide upon a rhythm and a bearing that is free, and then assign it a melody or words that are opposed to the rhythm. Nor would they ever combine the sounds of beasts, humans, mechanical devices, and noises of all sorts, into a unity, as though they were imitating one thing. But human poets, who

blend such sounds together with great relish and jumble them up without rhythm or reason, would provide great amusement to people who, as Orpheus¹⁹ says, “are ripe for delight”, when they see these all jumbled up. But the poets go further, and divorce rhythm and bearing from melody, put bare words to a metre, and leave melody and rhythm without any language by making use of the harp and the flute on their own. It is very difficult then to recognise, without words, what the rhythm and harmony signify, or what imitations worth mentioning they resemble. So, we need to understand that this sort of thing is crude in the extreme, as it is based on such a passion for speed, dexterity and animal sounds that it uses the flute and the harp in the absence of dance or song. But using either instrument on its own is the mark of a thoroughly uncultured trickster. That is where the theory of all this stands. But in our case we are not considering how our over thirty-year-olds and those who are over fifty should not practise music, but how exactly they should do so. At this stage, then, our argument is indicating that those over fifty-year-olds whose role will involve singing should receive a better education than they get from choral music. For they need to be well aware, themselves, of rhythms and harmonies and recognise them. How else could someone recognise the correctness of the melodies and know which is suited to the Dorian mode and which is not, or whether the rhythm that the poet assigned to this has been correctly assigned or not?

Clinias: No, it’s obvious that he could not do so at all.

670b

Athenian: Indeed, the general populace are being ridiculous when they believe they are up to the task of recognising what constitutes good rhythm and harmony and what does not when they have only been drilled in singing along and marching in step, and do not realise that they are engaging in these

activities in total ignorance. Whereas, in fact, every melody that has what is appropriate to it is constituted correctly, and if it has what is inappropriate to it, it is constituted improperly.

Clinias: That's quite inevitable.

670d

Athenian: What about someone who does not recognise what exactly the melody has? Will he ever recognise, as we were asking, whether it has been correctly constituted in any case?

Clinias: No, how could he?

Athenian: Well, it seems we are now discovering, once again, that these singers of ours whom we are encouraging – and, in a sense, compelling – of their own free will to sing need to have been educated to the following extent. They each need to be capable of following the steps of the rhythms and the chords of the melodies so that they may be able to select those that are appropriate and suitable for men of their age and character to sing. They would sing in this way, and as they sang they would enjoy innocent pleasures themselves, there and then, and would provide leadership to the younger generation in the proper appreciation of good character. Having been educated thus far, they would have access to a more rigorous education than what is made available to the general population, and indeed to the poets themselves. Indeed, it is not imperative that a poet recognises whether the imitation is beautiful or not beautiful, which was our third principle earlier, although it is well-nigh essential that he knows harmony and rhythm. But our elders need to know all three principles in order to decide what imitation is most exalted and what lies in second place, or they would never be up to the task of charming our young folk towards excellence. The argument intended, from the very outset, to demonstrate that our defence of the chorus of Dionysus was a noble undertaking, and it has now said so, as best it can. So let's consider whether it has actually succeeded.

Now, a gathering of this nature inevitably keeps on getting more and more boisterous, I presume, as the drinking proceeds, and we said initially that this is an unavoidable outcome in the cases we are now describing.

Clinias: Unavoidable.

671a

Athenian: Everyone is beside himself and has a joyful time. In this condition he does not listen to the others, but is free with his own speech, and he thinks he has become capable of ruling both himself and the others.

Clinias: Of course.

671b

Athenian: Now, didn't we say that when this happens, the souls of the drinkers, being heated like a piece of iron, become softer and younger? So, just as they were in their younger days, they are easily led by someone with the ability and the knowledge to train them and shape them. And the one who shapes them now is the one who shaped them then. This is the good lawgiver, who should give laws for the drinking party that are capable of making someone willingly do the exact opposite when he is so confident and bold, so improperly devoid of shame, so resistant to orderly behaviour, and so reluctant to observe in turn silence and speech, drinking and music. The laws should be able also to send forth, along with justice, that most exalted and divine fear which we call reverence and shame, to do battle against the ignoble courage.

Clinias: Quite so.

671d

Athenian: There should be legal guardians of these laws who work alongside them, as calm, sober generals set over men who are not sober, since doing battle against drunkenness without such men is more daunting than fighting your enemies without

calm commanders. And what is more, anyone who is unable willingly to obey these officers of Dionysus, the over sixty-year-olds, shall incur as much disgrace, and more, than those who disobey Ares' commanders on the battlefield.

Clinias: And rightly so.

671e

Athenian: Now, if there was this sort of drunkenness and this sort of entertainment, wouldn't such drinking companions be benefited, and part from one another better friends than they were previously, rather than parting as enemies, as they do nowadays? Wouldn't all their dealings with one another be conducted in accordance with the laws, following these whenever the sober men give the lead to those who are not sober?

Clinias: That's right, provided the party is as you are describing it.

672a

Athenian: Then let us not criticise the gift of Dionysus in this unqualified way any longer, saying that it is bad for the city and should be rejected. In fact, one could elaborate on this to an even greater extent. Yet I am reluctant to describe to most people the greatest good that it bestows, because people misunderstand and misinterpret what is said.

Clinias: What sort of benefit are you referring to?

672b

Athenian: There is a report and a tradition in circulation according to which, this god, Dionysus, was robbed of his soul's understanding by his stepmother, Hera, and because of this he introduced revelry and frenzied dancing to get his revenge. And that's the very reason why he gave us the gift of wine too.²⁰ Now, I leave such stories to those who think it safe to relate them about the gods, but this much I do know. No living

creature is ever born with the intelligence, or as much intelligence, as it should possess when it reaches maturity. During the stage of life in which it has not yet acquired its proper intelligence it is totally mad, makes disordered noises, and as soon as it can stand up it jumps about in a disordered manner too. And we should remind ourselves that the origins of both music and gymnastics, according to us, lie in such behaviour.

Clinias: We remember, of course.

672d

Athenian: Didn't we also say that this was the origin of the awareness of rhythm and harmony instilled in us humans, and that the gods responsible for this were Apollo, the Muses and Dionysus?

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: And, indeed, according to everyone else's account, wine, it seems, was given to humanity out of revenge, to make us mad, whereas our own account maintains, on the contrary, that it is a remedy, given so that we may acquire reverence of soul, and health and strength of body.

Clinias: Your recollection of the argument is excellent, stranger.

672e

Athenian: Let us say, then, that one half of choral performance has been dealt with fully. Shall we deal with the other half, as seems best, or shall we leave it?

Clinias: What are you referring to? What are the two divisions you are making?

Athenian: Choral performance as a whole was, for us, the process of education as a whole, and rhythm and harmony was the part of this that relates to the voice.

Clinias: Yes.

Athenian: But although the part that relates to the movement of the body and the part that relates to the movement of the voice have rhythm in common, bearing is unique to the body's motion, while melody is unique to the motion of the voice.

Clinias: Very true.

673a

Athenian: Now, those aspects of the education of the voice towards excellence, which actually reach the soul, we have for some reason called music.

Clinias: And rightly so.

Athenian: But the movements of the body in creatures at play we called dance. And when movement of this sort is conducive to the excellence of the body, we should refer to this skilled discipline of the body, when used for such a purpose, as gymnastics.

Clinias: Correct.

673b

Athenian: As for music, we said a moment ago that this half of choral performance had been described and dealt with fully, and we may say so again now. But what about the other half? What should be done about it, and how?

Clinias: My good man, you are conversing with Cretans and Spartans, and we have described music in detail, but we are leaving out gymnastics. So what sort of answer do you expect from either of us in reply to your question?

Athenian: I would say that you have responded in pretty plain terms to my question, by asking your question. Yes, I understand that although it is now a question, as I said, it is also an instruction to deal with the subject of gymnastics fully.

Clinias: You have understood very well, and you should act accordingly.

673c

Athenian: So I should. Indeed, there is no great difficulty in speaking to the two of you on matters you both know so well, for you are far more experienced in this art than in the other one.

Clinias: True enough.

Athenian: Well, the origin of this playfulness is the habitual leaping that is natural to all creatures. But the human being, as we said, having acquired an awareness of rhythm, developed and brought forth dance. And since melody brings to mind and awakens rhythm, the two combined together brought forth choral performance and play.

Clinias: Very true.

673d

Athenian: And we maintain that we have already dealt with one part of this, and we shall try to deal with the other part next.

Clinias: Yes, indeed.

Athenian: Well, if it is acceptable to you two, let us put the finishing touch to our discussion of the use of drunkenness first.

Clinias: What do you mean? What sort of finishing touch?

Athenian: What if some city makes serious use of the practice we are referring to, in a lawful and orderly manner, practising it in order to cultivate sound-mindedness? Suppose, in like manner, that it does not do away with the other pleasures, on the same principle, because it is aiming at mastery over them. Then this approach of ours should be applied to all these. But what if, on the other hand, this is regarded as entertainment, and anyone who likes is allowed to drink, whenever he likes, with whomsoever he pleases, while engaging in any sort of

behaviour at all? Then I could not cast my vote to allow this city or this man ever to have recourse to drunkenness. And I would go even further than the practice of the Cretans and Spartans, and propose the law of the Carthaginians, that no soldier may ever taste liquor whilst on campaign. He should, rather, become a water drinker for the entire duration. In the city too, no slave, male or female, should ever taste thereof, nor should a magistrate during his year in office, nor should steersmen or jurors ever taste wine at all whilst on duty, nor should any councillor who is attending a council meeting of any importance. In the daytime, no one should taste it at all except as part of a training regime or to treat a disease. Nor at night either, whenever a man or a woman intends to conceive a child. And one could mention very many other situations in which those in possession of reason and correct law should not drink wine. And so, according to the argument, no city should need lots of vineyards, and although agricultural production in general, and the entire lifestyle, would be regulated, the production of wine in particular would be more moderate and modest than anything else. So, dear strangers, let this, if you agree, be our finishing touch to the argument concerning wine.

Clinias: Well said. We agree.

BOOK III

676a

Athenian: So, let us leave this issue then. But what is the origin of a political system? What should we say? Wouldn't this be appreciated most easily, and in the best way, from the following perspective?

Clinias: From what perspective?

Athenian: The perspective from which we should always observe the progress and transformation of cities in the

direction of excellence or evil.

Clinias: What perspective do you mean?

676b

Athenian: The perspective, I believe, of a vast and limitless span of time and of the changes that occur within it.

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: Come on now, for a very long time there have been cities and people have lived as citizens. Do you think we could ever discern for how long this has been so?

Clinias: That would not be at all easy.

Athenian: Well, at any rate, the time period would be immense and enormous.

Clinias: That is certainly so.

676c

Athenian: Haven't thousands upon thousands of cities come into existence over that time period, and, by the same reckoning, haven't just as many of them perished, and haven't they each been governed at one time or another by all sorts of political systems? Sometimes a large city has arisen from a small one, and at other times a small one from a large one, better has arisen from worse, and worse from better.

Clinias: Inevitably.

Athenian: Then let us discover the cause of this transformation, if we are able, for that might perhaps reveal to us how political systems come into existence in the first place, and how they change.

Clinias: Well said. So, we should get on with it, you to explain what you have in mind on these matters, and the two of us to follow along.

677a

Athenian: Well then, do the ancient accounts seem to you to possess any degree of truth?

Clinias: Which ones?

Athenian: Those saying that humanity has been destroyed many times by floods, plagues, and lots of other disasters, after which only a small remnant of the human race was left.

Clinias: Yes, indeed, everyone finds a story like this convincing.

Athenian: Come on then, let us think about one of these many destructions, the one that happened once because of the flood.²¹

Clinias: What line of thought do you want us to pursue?

^{677b}

Athenian: That those who escaped the destruction at the time would almost all be mountain-dwelling shepherds, I presume, little embers of the human race surviving among the high mountain peaks.

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: And, indeed, men like this necessarily lack experience in the other skills, and especially in the devices employed against one another by city dwellers to further their greed and ambition, and any other foul deeds they decide to inflict on one another.

Clinias: Quite likely.

Athenian: Now, may we assume that the cities situated on the plains or by the sea were destroyed totally at the time?

Clinias: We may.

^{677c}

Athenian: Wouldn't all their tools be destroyed too, and if some significant skill in the realm of politics or any other branch of wisdom had been discovered, shall we say that all these also disappeared at the time? For, best of men, if these inventions

had remained all the while as undisturbed as they are now, how would anything new ever have been discovered?

Clinias: This means that for countless ages these matters were unknown to people at that time, but in the past thousand or two thousand years some have been revealed to Daedalus, others to Orpheus or Palamedes, matters musical to Marsyas and Olympus, the lyre to Amphion, and lots of other matters to various others, all, so to speak, just yesterday or the day before.²²

677d

Athenian: It is good of you, Clinias, to omit mention of your acquaintance who was literally a man of just yesterday.

Clinias: You mean Epimenides, don't you?

Athenian: Yes, the very man. Indeed, he far surpassed every one of you with his invention, my friend. Hesiod had an intuition about it in theory, long before, but this man realised it in action, as you people say.²³

Clinias: Yes, that's what we say.

Athenian: Should we say that the situation for the human race after the destruction occurred was as follows? In spite of the terrible and widespread desolation, there was still a vast expanse of available land, and although most other living creatures had disappeared, some herds of cattle, and perhaps some goats, happened to survive, and these initially provided some meagre sustenance at the time.

Clinias: Indeed.

677e

Athenian: Now, our present argument has dealt with cities, political systems and legislation. Do you think there would, in any sense, have been any memory of these at all?

Clinias: Not at all.

Athenian: Now, it is from those people living under such circumstances, isn't it, that everything we have nowadays has arisen – our cities, our political systems, our skills and our laws, a lot of degeneracy and a great deal of excellence too?

Clinias: How do you mean?

678a

Athenian: Do we imagine, my good man, that the people of that time, with no experience of all the good associated with city life, or the many evils either, were ever completely excellent or completely evil?

Clinias: A good question. Yes, we now understand the point you are making.

Athenian: But with the passage of time and the multiplication of our race, everything eventually came to be as everything is now.

Clinias: Correct.

678b

Athenian: But this in all likelihood did not happen suddenly, but gradually over an enormous span of time.

Clinias: Most likely, indeed.

Athenian: Yes, for they were all, I imagine, haunted still by the fear of coming down from the high places to the plains.

Clinias: Of course.

678c

Athenian: Now, although they were always glad to see one another in those days, because there were so few of them, any means of transportation by land or by sea to visit one another had, for the most part, all perished, so to speak, along with the relevant skills. So I do not think they found it at all easy to get together. For iron and bronze and all other metals had disappeared in the flood, and there were no means at all of

extracting such materials from the earth, and consequently there was a shortage of timber. Indeed, any tools that had survived in the mountains were quickly worn out and disappeared, never to reappear until the skill of working with metal had been restored to humanity.

Clinias: Indeed, how could they have tools?

678d

Athenian: How many generations later do you think this happened?

Clinias: Very many, of course.

Athenian: And wouldn't any skills that required iron and bronze, and anything of that sort, also have disappeared for the same amount of time or even longer?

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: Then civil strife and warfare too disappeared at the time for a variety of reasons.

Clinias: How so?

678e

Athenian: In the first place, they were kind and had a friendly disposition towards one another because of their isolation. And what is more, food was not a matter of contention for them, for there was no shortage of pastureland except perhaps in some cases initially, and most of them lived off this at the time. Indeed, they were not at all lacking in milk or in meat, and they provided plenty more wholesome food for themselves by hunting. And, indeed, they were quite well off for clothing, bedding, dwellings, and vessels for cooking and for other purposes. For the skills that involve moulding and weaving do not require any iron, and God gave both these skills to humanity to provide all these necessities, so that whenever the human race faced a challenge of this sort, it would still be able to

develop and progress. Now, under such circumstances they were not especially poor, nor did poverty force them into conflict with themselves. Yet, they could never become wealthy either in the absence of gold and silver, which they did not have then. Now, the noblest characters of all generally arise in a society in which neither poverty nor riches reside, since violence and injustice, rivalry and jealousy find no place there. Because of all this, and because of their so-called simple-mindedness too, they were good people. Indeed, such was their simple-mindedness that whenever they heard something described as noble or as base, they took this to be the very truth, and they believed what was said. For unlike people nowadays, none of them knew how to use wisdom in order to suspect falsehood. So they took what is said about the gods and humanity to be true, and they lived in accordance with what is said. Consequently they were, in every respect, the sort of people we have been describing.

Clinias: Well, I agree with you on this anyway, and so does this man here.

679d

Athenian: Therefore, shouldn't we say that the many generations who lived in this way were bound to be less skilled and have less understanding of skills in general than people born before the flood, or people nowadays, especially the military skills practised now in land battles or on the open seas, or, indeed, in the city itself, where they are called law suits and civil factions which contrive, by word and deed, to inflict mutual harm and injustice by every possible means? Weren't they simpler, more courageous people, more sound-minded too, and altogether more just? And we have already explained the cause of all this.

Clinias: That's right.

679e

Athenian: Now, whatever we have said, and anything we will say next as a consequence, all has a purpose. We want to appreciate what need the people of that era had for laws, and who their lawmaker was.

Clinias: Yes, you put that very well.

Athenian: Wasn't it the case that they had no need of lawgivers in that age, nor indeed was anything of this sort likely to arise then? For people born during that part of the cycle²⁴ did not yet even possess the art of writing; they lived, rather, in accordance with custom and the so-called laws of their forefathers.

Clinias: Quite likely.

680a

Athenian: And yet, this already constitutes some manner of political system.

Clinias: What manner?

Athenian: The political system of that era, which is still prevalent nowadays among the Greeks and the non-Greeks too, is what everyone, I believe, calls a dynasty. Homer says that this system constituted the domestic arrangement of the Cyclopes, and he says: "These people have no institutions, no meetings for counsels; rather they make their habitations in caverns hollowed among the peaks of the high mountains, and each one is the law for his own wives and children, and cares nothing about the others."²⁵

680b

Clinias: It seems that this poet of yours was quite charming. In fact, we have also studied other verses of his which were most sophisticated, not many though, since we Cretans are not much in the habit of using foreign poetry.

Megillus: As for ourselves in Sparta, we do make use of Homer, and he seems superior to other poets of this sort, even though

the way of life he generally describes is more Ionian than Spartan. But just now he seems to support your argument, when his story attributes the ancient system of these fellows to their wildness.

680c

Athenian: Yes, he does provide support, and we may use him as evidence indicating that political systems of this sort do arise on occasion.

Clinias: Good.

Athenian: Don't these originate from the people who were dispersed into single family units or clans due to the difficulty during the destructions? Under such systems, doesn't the eldest person exercise authority because authority originates from the father and mother, whom they follow like birds? Don't they form a single flock living under paternal law, and a kingship that is the most just kingship of all?

Clinias: Very much so.

680d

Athenian: After all this, they come together in larger numbers, thus forming cities. They take to farming, at first in the foothills, building enclosures surrounded by dry stone walls to provide a defence against wild animals, and they construct a single large common dwelling place.

Clinias: Yes, that's likely to be how all this happens.

Athenian: There is something else that is likely too.

Clinias: What?

680e

Athenian: These dwelling places grew in size out of the lesser units that were there initially. Each of the small units arrived, clan by clan, with its own ruling elder and its own particular customs, because of the fact that they had dwelled apart from

one another. Since those who begot and reared them were different in each case, the customs they adopted concerning the gods and themselves were different too. They were more orderly when they had more orderly ancestors, and more courageous when they had more courageous ones. So, as we were saying, each group arrived into the larger unit having its own particular laws, and, accordingly, each imposed its own preferences upon their children and their children's children.

Clinias: Yes, it's inevitable.

681c

Athenian: And it is also inevitable, I presume, that each group would favour its own laws over the laws of others.

Clinias: Quite so.

Athenian: It seems then that we have somehow unwittingly made a foray into the origins of legislation.

Clinias: It does indeed.

Athenian: In any case, what's needed next is for these groups that have come together to choose some representative from among their number who will review all of the regulations. Whatever regulations they most favour for common use, they will present openly and put them forward for adoption by the various leaders and chiefs of the people, who are, in a sense, their kings. The representatives themselves will be called lawgivers, and once they have put rulers in place and thus formed an aristocracy, or indeed a kingship, instead of the dynasties, they will themselves live under this transformed political system.

681d

Clinias: Yes, that's what would happen next, albeit gradually.

Athenian: Well, let us go on to speak of a third sort of political system that arises. In this system all forms of political systems,

and of cities too, converge together, and all sorts of things happen to them.

Clinias: What sort is this?

681e

Athenian: The one that Homer too indicated as coming after the second when he said that the third sort arose as follows: “He founded Dardania,” he says, I believe, “since there was yet no sacred Ilium he made a city in the plain to be a centre of peoples, but they lived yet in the foothills of Ida.”²⁶ Yes, these lines that he speaks, and the others about the Cyclopes too, are in accord somehow with God and with nature. For the poetical folk, being inspired when they are singing, are also, indeed, divine, and in the company of some Graces and Muses they often lay hold of a true version of events.

682a

Clinias: Yes, very much so.

Athenian: Let us delve further into the story that is engaging us now, since it may perhaps indicate something relevant to our overall purpose. Shouldn’t we do so?

Clinias: Yes, indeed.

682b

Athenian: Ilium was founded, we maintain, when they moved down from the high places to a vast and beautiful plain. It was situated on a low ridge that had numerous rivers coming down from Mount Ida.

Clinias: Yes, so they say.

Athenian: Don’t we think that this happened many years after the deluge?

Clinias: Yes, it must have been many years later.

682c

Athenian: At any rate, they were, it seems, strangely forgetful of the disaster we are speaking of, since they located their city in this way, below numerous rivers flowing down from the high places, and put their trust in some ridges of no great height.

Clinias: It is obvious then that they were separated from the disaster by an enormous interval of time.

682d

Athenian: And many other cities, I imagine, had already been founded by then as the human race increased in numbers.

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: These presumably waged war against Ilium, and they probably did so by sea, since by then they were all taking to the sea fearlessly.

Clinias: Apparently.

Athenian: And after a ten-year wait, the Achaeans sacked Troy.

Clinias: They certainly did.

Athenian: Now, during this ten-year period when Ilium was under siege, matters unfolded very badly for the various besiegers in their own countries because of rebellion on the part of the younger generation. And when the combatants got back to their own cities and homes, the young did not receive them in a noble and just manner, and so there was death, slaughter and exile on a huge scale. Those who had been expelled came back again under a changed name, being called Dorians rather than Achaeans, after Dorieus who had gathered the exiles together at the time. And you Spartans tell the story of all the events that happened after this, and you describe them in detail.

Megillus: Indeed.

682e

Athenian: Well, as if by divine intervention, we have now arrived back again at the very point from which we digressed in the early stages of our discussion about laws, when we came across the subject of music and drunkenness. And our argument is letting us come to grips with it, so to speak, for it has come around to the establishment of Sparta itself, and you maintain that Sparta was established correctly, as was Crete, which has kindred laws. So, we have now gained this much advantage from the wandering course of our argument, as we deal with various political systems and settlements; in the settlements we have seen a first, second and third city succeeding one another, we believe, over some immense span of time. And now this fourth city,²⁷ or nation if you prefer, has arrived. It was once in the process of being founded, and has now been founded. Now, perhaps we might be able to understand from all this what has been properly founded and what has not, what sort of laws save those that are saved, or ruin those that are ruined, and what sort of changes, in what respects, would produce a happy city. If we can do so, dear Megillus and Clinias, then we should state all this once more as if we were starting all over again, unless we find some fault with the earlier arguments.

683b

Megillus: Well, stranger, if some god were to promise us that, in return for making a second attempt at the enquiry into legislation, we would hear arguments that are no worse and no shorter than what has just been presented, I for one would willingly go far to hear it, and this day would seem short to me, even though it is almost the summer solstice when the god turns summer days towards winter.

Athenian: It seems we should conduct an enquiry then.

Megillus: Very much so.

683c

Athenian: Then let us use our imagination to place ourselves in that age when Sparta, Argos, Messene and their adjacent territories, had all more or less come under the control of your ancestors. They decided next, so the story goes, to divide the host into three, thus founding three cities, Argos, Messene and Sparta.

Megillus: Yes, indeed.

683d

Athenian: And Temenus became king of Argos, Cresphontes of Messene, and Procles and Eurysthenes of Sparta.

Megillus: Of course.

683e

Athenian: And everyone at the time swore an oath to these kings to come to their aid should anyone ever try to destroy their kingdom.

Megillus: Indeed.

Athenian: But, by Zeus, is a kingdom ever brought down, or indeed has any government ever been brought down, by anything else besides the rulers themselves? Or have we now forgotten that we proposed this a short time ago in those arguments we came across?

Megillus: No, how could we forget?

684a

Athenian: In that case, we can now make this position more certain, since we have come across historical events that seem to bring us to the same argument. Accordingly, we shall be investigating it on the basis of something that actually happened in truth, rather than something abstract. What actually happened was as follows: each of the three kingships, and the cities over which they reigned, swore an oath to one another in accordance with the common laws which they had instituted about ruling and being ruled. The rulers swore not to

make their rule more oppressive as the years and the generations advanced. The subjects swore that as long as the rulers upheld the agreement, they themselves would never subvert their kingship nor allow others to do so. Kings swore to come to the aid of kings, and of the people too, when they were wronged, and the people swore to aid other peoples, and kings too, when they were wronged. Isn't this so?

Megillus: It is indeed.

684b

Athenian: Wasn't this the most important factor in the settled order of the political systems in the three cities as established by law, whether enacted by kings or anyone else?

Megillus: What?

Athenian: That two cities are always allies set against the other one, if it ever disregards the established laws.

Megillus: Of course.

684c

Athenian: And, indeed, most people insist that their legislators pass the sort of laws that the general populace will accept willingly. It's as if a trainer or physician had to look after and cure people's bodies in a pleasant way.

Megillus: Entirely so.

Athenian: But very often it is quite satisfactory if one can bring about a sound and healthy condition of the body, without the involvement of an enormous amount of pain.

Megillus: Indeed.

684d

Athenian: And the legislators at the time had a further, not insignificant, advantage in instituting their laws easily.

Megillus: What sort of advantage?

Athenian: The legislators were not subject to one very serious accusation as they set about ensuring equality of wealth, an accusation that arises in many other cities when they are passing laws. Whenever someone seeks to make a change in land ownership or to cancel debts, because he sees that without such measures it would not ever be possible for equality to arise to any significant extent, he meets resistance. Everyone opposes a lawgiver who attempts to change anything of this sort, telling him not to disturb the fixed systems, and they curse him for introducing the redistribution of land and the abolition of debts, with the result that everyone ends up perplexed. But for the Dorians there was also the advantage that all this worked out nicely and without any evil consequences, because there was no dispute over the distribution of land, and there were no large, long-standing debts.

Megillus: True.

685a

Athenian: Then why ever, best of men, did their settlement and legislation turn out as badly as it did?

Megillus: In what way? What fault do you find with them?

Athenian: That although three states were founded, two of the three quickly subverted their own political systems and their laws, and one alone has remained as it was, and that is your city, Megillus.

Megillus: You are asking a difficult question.

Athenian: And yet this is what we should now consider and investigate as we play this sober old men's game concerning laws, to relieve the pain of our journey, as we said when we first set out.

Megillus: Indeed. We should do as you say.

685b

Athenian: Well, when it comes to laws, what better enquiry could we make than an enquiry into the laws by which these states have been regulated? And when it comes to the foundation of cities, could we consider any that are greater and more renowned than these?

Megillus: Apart from these, it is not easy to name any others.

685c

Athenian: Well, this much is fairly obvious, the people of that era intended this arrangement as an adequate protection, not just for the Peloponnese, but for all of Greece, in case any of the non-Greek peoples should do them wrong. This is just what those who lived around Ilium did at the time. They placed such trust in the might of the Assyrians as it stood during the reign of Ninus²⁸ that they arrogantly provoked the war against Troy. For the still surviving grandeur of the Assyrian empire was quite considerable, and the Greeks of the time feared its unified structure, just as we fear the Great King nowadays.²⁹ Indeed, the second taking of Troy³⁰ became a great reproach against the Greeks since it was part of the empire of the Assyrians. To deal with all these issues, there was that single arrangement of military forces, divided then into three cities under the command of three kings who were brothers, as they were all sons of Heracles. This, it seems, was an excellent arrangement, superior indeed to the Trojan expedition. For in the first place, these sons of Heracles were regarded as better commanders than the sons of Pelops.³¹ And what's more, this military force was thought to be superior in excellence to the Trojan expedition which consisted of Achaeans, who, although they had been victorious at Troy, were later defeated by the Dorians. Don't we imagine that people organised themselves in this way in those days, and with this intention?

Megillus: Entirely so.

685e

Athenian: Now, weren't they also likely to presume that these arrangements would possess some stability, and would last for a considerable period of time, since they had shared many hardships and dangers together, and had been organised under the command of a single family, their kings being brothers? What's more, they had consulted many oracles among whom was Apollo of Delphi.

Megillus: Yes, that is most likely.

686a

Athenian: But these high hopes, it seems, took flight and were gone soon after, except, as we said just now, for a small part of the alliance, the part in your region, and this has engaged in uninterrupted warfare against the other two parts, right down to the present day. But if the original intention had come to fruition, and they had agreed upon a single aim, they would have possessed military power that none could withstand.

Megillus: Inevitably.

686b

Athenian: So, how was it destroyed and what led to its destruction? Isn't it worth investigating what turn of fortune brought down such a great confederacy as this?

Megillus: Yes. For anyone who neglects these issues and investigates something else would hardly catch sight of laws and political systems that preserve such great and noble undertakings, or indeed, on the contrary, bring them down completely.

686c

Athenian: Well, in that case, it seems we have fortunately embarked somehow upon a significant investigation.

Megillus: We have, indeed.

Athenian: So, my good man, are we now, like most people, unwittingly presuming every time we see some good object that

it would accomplish something wonderful if only someone knew, somehow or other, how to use this properly? But perhaps we are neither thinking correctly nor in accordance with nature about this very issue, and neither is anyone else who thinks in this way about any other matters.

Megillus: What do you mean? What exactly is this argument of yours concerned with? What can we say?

686d

Athenian: My good man, I was laughing just now at my own behaviour. For as soon as I beheld this host we are talking about, it seemed glorious to me and a wonderful acquisition for the Greeks to come by, if only, as I said, someone had used it properly at the time.

Megillus: Wasn't it sound and reasonable for you to say all this, and for us to endorse it too?

686e

Athenian: Perhaps. At any rate, I am of the view that everyone who sees something of significance, possessing power and a lot of strength, immediately feels that if only its possessor knew how to use this, being the sort of thing it is, being as great as it is, he would produce wonderful results aplenty, and would enjoy happiness.

Megillus: That's correct too, isn't it? Or what do you say?

687a

Athenian: Well, consider this. What should a person look to to ensure that he says the right thing when bestowing such praise on anything? Firstly, in the case we are now discussing, if those who were organising the military force at the time had known how to arrange it properly, how would they have set about achieving their objective? Wouldn't they have had good grounds for praising the arrangement if they had set it up securely, safe for all time, so that they themselves were free and

had authority over others as they wished, and that they themselves, and their descendants too, could do as they pleased among their fellow men, Greeks and barbarians alike?

Megillus: Entirely so.

687b

Athenian: And isn't it also the case that someone who sees enormous wealth or exceptional family prestige, or anything else of that sort, might say the very same things? He looks at this and assumes that through this someone might obtain everything he desires, or the most significant part of it anyway.

Megillus: Quite likely.

687c

Athenian: Come on then, is there one object of desire, common to all men, that is now being revealed by the argument, according to the argument itself?

Megillus: What sort of desire?

Athenian: That whatever happens would take place according to the command of his own soul, in most cases, or failing that in the case of human affairs at least.

Megillus: Indeed.

687d

Athenian: Now, since all of us, children and old men alike, are wishing for something of this sort all of the time, wouldn't we also necessarily pray for this constantly?

Megillus: Inevitably.

Athenian: And, indeed, we would presumably join our loved ones in prayer for whatever they pray for themselves.

Megillus: Indeed.

Athenian: Now, a son, who is a child, is loved by his father, who is a man.

Megillus: Of course.

Athenian: And yet in many cases, the father might pray to the gods that what the son prays for, for himself, would never come to pass at all.

Megillus: You mean when the prayers are uttered while his son is still young and foolish?

687e

Athenian: But what if the father, because of his old age, or out of sheer impetuosity, with no recognition of what's good and just, prays with great eagerness whilst gripped by passions akin to those of Theseus towards his son Hippolytus, who died so tragically?³² Do you think that a son who realises this will join in the prayers of his father?

Megillus: I understand your meaning. Indeed, you seem to me to be saying that a man must not pray and strive that everything conform to his own wishes, but that his wishes conform to his own wisdom. Every city, and each and every one of us, should pray and be eager for this – to possess reason.

688a

Athenian: Yes, and a statesman or lawgiver especially should always look to this when putting legal arrangements in place. And I am myself reminded, and I am reminding the two of you, that at the beginning of our discussion, if you recall, your principle was that the good lawgiver should institute all regulations for the sake of war. But I maintained that this would encourage them to institute the laws, aiming at only one of the four excellences, when they should really look to all four, but most of all and primarily to the chief and leader of all excellence combined. This would be wisdom, reason and opinion, along with the love and desire that follow them. So, our argument has arrived back at the same place once more, and I am now saying once again what I said then in jest, if you please, or in all

seriousness, that to have recourse to prayer without possessing reason is perilous, and what unfolds is the opposite of what was wished for. You may take me seriously if you wish to do so, for I really expect that you will discover, if you follow the argument we put forward a while ago, that the cause of the destruction of the kingdoms, and of the entire plan of action, was not cowardice or ignorance of warfare on the part of the rulers or their proper subjects. They were ruined by evil in general, but mostly by ignorance of the most important of human undertakings. Now, since we are friends, I shall try my best to discover and to show you, if you like, by going systematically through the argument that this was how matters unfolded at the time, and still unfold today given similar circumstances, and that hereafter nothing will happen in a different way.

688c

Clinias: Well, stranger, mere words of praise would be an insult to you, so we shall praise you heartily with our deeds, for we shall follow what you say eagerly, and that's how a free born man makes his approval or disapproval most evident.

Megillus: Excellent, Clinias, we should do so as, you say.

Clinias: Let it be so, God willing. Speak on.

688d

Athenian: So, following the remaining course of the argument, we maintain that what destroyed the power at that time was enormous ignorance, and naturally it still does the same thing today. Accordingly, if this is so, the lawgiver must try to implant as much wisdom as he can in the cities, and do his very best to eradicate ignorance.

Clinias: Of course.

689a

Athenian: What kind of ignorance may justifiably be called the greatest? Decide whether you both agree with what I say, for I

am going to make a suggestion.

Clinias: What is it?

Athenian: It is the ignorance whereby something seems noble and good to someone, but he does not love this, but hates it, and loves and welcomes what seems degenerate and unjust. This discord between pleasure and pain on the one hand, and reasoned opinion on the other, is, I maintain, the utmost and greatest ignorance because it pervades most of the soul. Indeed, the part of the soul that feels pain and pleasure corresponds to the general populace of a city. Now, when this part is opposed to knowledge, opinion and reason – the soul's natural ruling elements – this I call folly in a city, when most of the people do not obey the rulers and the laws. And it's the same in a single individual too when the noble principles present in the soul accomplish nothing, but have the very opposite effect. All these, I would suggest, constitute the most discordant forms of ignorance in a city, and, indeed, in any one of its citizens, but not the ignorance of its workmen, if you understand me, strangers.

Clinias: We understand, my friend, and we agree with what you are saying.

689c

Athenian: So that's settled then, and let it be resolved and proclaimed that no authority should be entrusted to those who are in the grip of such ignorance. They should be censured for their ignorance, even if they are highly rational and well trained in all sorts of cleverness, and in everything that naturally produces a quick-witted soul. Those, however, who are more or less the opposite of these fellows should be hailed as wise, and authority should be given to them because they are sensible people, even if as the saying goes, "they don't know how to read or to swim". For how, my friends, could there be wisdom even to the slightest extent in the absence of concord?

There could not. But the greatest and most exalted concord may quite rightly be called the greatest wisdom, and whoever lives in accord with reason shares in this. But he who is devoid of this turns out, time and again, to be a subverter of his household and no saviour of his city, but the exact opposite because of his foolishness in these respects. So, as we just said, let this stand as our declaration.

Clinias: Yes, let it stand.

689e

Athenian: Now, in our cities there must, I presume, be people who rule and people who are ruled.

Clinias: Indeed.

690a

Athenian: So be it. And how many rights, of what sort, to rule and be ruled, are there in cities large or small, and in households too in like manner? Isn't one of these the right of father and mother? And, in general, wouldn't the right of parents to rule over their offspring be accepted everywhere?

Clinias: Very much so.

Athenian: Following from this, is the right of the well-born to rule over the base-born, and thirdly, as a consequence of these, that the elder should rule and the younger be ruled.

Clinias: Indeed.

690b

Athenian: And fourthly, that slaves should be ruled and their masters should rule them.

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: Fifthly, I believe that the stronger should rule and the weaker should be ruled.

Clinias: Yes, that one is quite inevitable.

690c

Athenian: Yes, and this one is prevalent among all living creatures, and it accords with nature, as Pindar the Theban once said.³³ But the most important right, it seems, would be the sixth, declaring that the wise should lead and rule, and anyone devoid of knowledge should follow. And yet, O wise Pindar, I myself could never maintain that such natural rule of law over willing subjects, without use of force, is contrary to nature. It accords with nature.

Clinias: Absolutely correct.

Athenian: We say that the seventh form of rule involves the favour of god and good fortune. So we introduce people to a lottery system, and the most just outcome, we maintain, is that he to whom the lot falls should rule, while he who fails should depart and be ruled.

Clinias: Very true.

690d

Athenian: And to someone who sets about instituting laws in a light-hearted manner, we might say playfully, “My dear lawmaker, do you see then just how many rights there are relating to rulership, and that they are naturally in conflict with one another? In fact, we have now discovered a wellspring of conflicts which you need to remedy. But first, join us in an enquiry as to how the kings of Argos and Messene destroyed themselves and, simultaneously, the power of the Greeks which was so wondrous at the time. What was their transgression of these rights? Wasn’t it their ignorance of the excellent maxim of Hesiod that the half is often more than the whole?³⁴ Meaning that when it is ruinous to get the whole, and half is the right measure, he thought that what’s measured aright is more because it is better than what’s unmeasured and worse.”

Clinias: A very true saying indeed.

690e

Athenian: Now, do we think that this brings about destruction when it arises among kings or among the general population?

Clinias: Well, this is likely for the most part to be a disease of kings because of their opulent and luxurious lifestyle.

691a

Athenian: Isn't it clear, then, that the kings at the time were the first to catch this disease of greed for more than the established laws allowed? There was no concord among them on the very agreement they had sworn to adhere to under oath, and this discord, which, according to us, is the greatest ignorance even though it seems like wisdom, destroyed everything through a discordant and strident unmusicality.

Clinias: Quite likely.

691b

Athenian: So be it. Now, what precaution should the lawgiver have taken at the time to ensure that this affliction did not arise? By the gods, it takes no wisdom to understand this today and the question is easy to answer, but if it could have been foreseen at the time, whoever had foreseen it would have been wiser than any of us.

Megillus: What are you referring to?

Athenian: By looking at what happened among your people, Megillus, it is possible today to come to an understanding, and then say quite readily what should have happened at that time.

Megillus: Explain this more clearly.

Athenian: The clearest explanation would be along the following lines.

Megillus: What?

691c

Athenian: If someone gives the greater to the lesser, be it a sail to a ship, food to a body, authority to a soul, without regard for the measure, he turns everything upside down, and in their wantonness some will run to disease, others to injustice born of arrogance. So what exactly are we saying? Is it something like this? There is no mortal soul whose nature will ever be able to bear supreme authority over human beings while still being young and irresponsible. Its thinking will be filled with ignorance, that terrible disease, so that the soul comes to hate its nearest and dearest, and when this happens, soul itself is quickly destroyed and all of its power comes to nothing. Now, to guard against this by understanding the measure is the mark of great lawgivers. So, today it is quite reasonable to guess that this actually happened at that time, but it seems there was also...

Megillus: What?

^{691d}

Athenian: There was some god caring for you who foresaw the impending events and expanded your line of kings to two instead of one, thus reducing their power more in the direction of due measure.³⁵ As well as this, someone³⁶ whose human nature had a mixture of divine power saw that your government was still at fever pitch. So he blended the sound-minded power of old age with the self-willed strength of the royal line by making the vote of the twenty-eight elders equal to the power of the kings on the most important matters. And your third saviour,³⁷ observing that your government was still wanton and inflamed, cast a sort of bridle around them, and this was the power of the ephors,³⁸ which is close enough to the power of the lottery. And, according to this account, your kingdom, constituted from the appropriate mixture of elements and possessed of due measure, having saved itself, went on to become responsible for the salvation of the others.³⁹ Since, if

this had been left to Temenus and Cresphontes and the legislators at the time, whoever those legislators may have been, they were not sufficiently experienced in the business of legislation, so even the portion belonging to Aristodemus⁴⁰ would not have survived. Otherwise they would hardly have presumed, with a few oaths, to bring measure to a young soul that had just acquired a position of authority that could develop into a tyranny. But now, the god has shown what rulership should have been like then, and should indeed be like now, if it is to endure. For us to recognise all this now that it has already happened is, as I said earlier, no mark of wisdom, since it is not difficult to see something from an example from the past. But if someone had foreseen all this at the time and had been able to moderate the rulers and unify the three of them, all the noble aspirations of that era would have been preserved, and no Persian horde or any other would ever have attacked Greece, despising us as people of no account.

Clinias: True.

^{692d}

Athenian: At any rate, they repulsed them, Clinias, in a disgraceful manner. And by disgraceful I don't mean that the men of that age were not victorious, and I am not denying that they won notable battles by land and by sea. No, I maintain that what was disgraceful at the time was, firstly, that of these three cities only one came to the defence of Greece. The other two were so badly corrupted that one of them⁴¹ even impeded Sparta in her defence of Greece by fighting against her with all its might, while the other, Argos, in spite of its primacy at the time of the original division, when called upon to defend Greece against the barbarians, paid no heed and did not defend her. And a lot more could be said about what went on during that war which would not reflect at all well on Greece. In fact, it wouldn't even be right to say that Greece defended itself,

because if the joint enterprise of the Athenians and the Spartans had not repulsed that impending enslavement, almost all the Greek nations would have been intermixed with one another by now – barbarians with Greeks, and Greeks with non-Greeks. This is exactly the situation of those who are under the tyranny of Persia nowadays. Having been dispersed and then jumbled together, they live out their lives wretchedly in scattered communities. These, Megillus and Clinias, are the criticisms we must direct at the so-called statesmen and lawmakers of past ages and of today, so that by investigating the causes of these failings, we may discover what other courses of action besides these they should have adopted. For instance, in the present case we said that we should not pass laws creating positions of authority that are too powerful, or indeed too pure. We should, rather, keep in mind that the city should be free, wise, and a friend to itself, and the lawgiver should pass laws with his eye fixed upon this aim. Now, we have already proposed certain aims many times that the lawgiver should look to when passing laws, but we should not be surprised if the proposals seem different to us on each occasion. We need to reckon for ourselves that when we maintain that he should look to sound-mindedness, or to wisdom or friendship, these aims are not different but the same, and we should not be troubled if various other expressions of this sort occur.

693c

Clinias: We shall try to do as you suggest as we go back over the arguments. But now tell us, in the case of friendship, wisdom and freedom, what were you intending to say the lawgiver should aim at?

693d

Athenian: Listen then. It would be right to say that there are, as it were, two mother-forms of political systems from which all others arise: one is called monarchy, the other democracy. The extreme of the former is the Persian system, while that of the

latter is ours. The others are practically all, as I said, variations of these two. Now, a city must necessarily have a share in both of these if it is to have freedom and friendship accompanied by wisdom. This, then, is what our argument wishes to prescribe by saying that a city could never be properly governed in the absence of these two.

Clinias: Indeed, how could it be?

693e

Athenian: Well, the Persian regime has embraced the monarchic, while the other, ours, has favoured freedom exclusively, to a greater extent than they should in each case. Neither regime has got both of these in the right measure, but your regimes in Sparta and Crete do have it more. So did the Athenians and Persians in ancient times, but this is less so nowadays. Should we give the reasons why? What do you think?

Clinias: Of course, if we are serious about pursuing our objective.

694a

Athenian: Listen then. The Persians, during the reign of Cyrus,⁴² observing the proper measure of subservience and freedom, first attained freedom themselves, and then attained supremacy over many others. For, as rulers, they granted freedom to their subjects and maintained equality, so the soldiers were well disposed towards the generals and didn't hold back in the face of danger. And what's more, if anyone among them was wise and capable of offering advice, the king did not begrudge him that opportunity. He allowed free speech and respected those who could assist him in his deliberations, and so the benefit of a man's wisdom was made available to the community at its very heart. In fact, everything prospered for them in those days because of this freedom, friendship and communal spirit.

Clinias: Well, that's likely to be how things happened, anyway.

694c

Athenian: How was it ever destroyed under Cambyses,⁴³ and more or less restored again under Darius? Would you like us to use some sort of prophetic sense to come up with an answer?

Clinias: That might help with the enquiry we have embarked upon.

Athenian: The sense I now have of Cyrus is that although he was a good general who loved his city, he had no contact at all with the right sort of education, and had never applied his mind to economics.

Clinias: Why would we say this?

694d

Athenian: He spent his life, it seems, from his earliest years, on military campaigns, and entrusted the upbringing of his children to women, who reared them from their very childhood as though they were already favoured with the blessings of heaven, with no deficiencies. The women would allow no one to oppose the children in anything because they were so blessed, and they made everyone else praise whatever the children said or did. So they brought them up to be people of a particular sort.

Clinias: A noble upbringing, it seems.

694e

Athenian: A feminine one, as you would expect from women of the royal household who had recently become rich, who were rearing children in the absence of any men, because they were all caught up in warfare with all its perils.

Clinias: That makes sense.

Athenian: But their father acquired flocks for them, sheep too and herds of humans, and various collections of all sorts of

things, but he did not realise that he was about to give all this to boys who had not been educated in their fathers' own skill, the skill of a Persian. The Persians were shepherds, sprung from a harsh land, and their skill was a tough one, just what was needed to produce very strong shepherds well able to live in the open air, go without sleep, and serve in the army if necessary. He simply did not notice that his sons, having been educated by women and eunuchs, had received a corrupted Median education⁴⁴ because of their so-called blessedness. So, having been brought up without hearing a word of reproach, they turned out to be the sort of people you would expect from such an upbringing. Now, when Cyrus died and the children inherited the kingdom, they were infected with luxury and licentiousness. First, one killed the other because he was angry over their equal status, but after that, he himself, maddened by drink and ill-education, lost his kingdom to the Medes and the so-called eunuch,⁴⁵ who had such utter contempt for the foolishness of Cambyses.

Clinias: That's what's said anyway, and it's quite likely that is more or less what happened.

695c

Athenian: And, indeed, it is also said, I believe, that authority reverted to the Persians through Darius and the 'Seven'.⁴⁶

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: Let us look at this then, by following the account. For Darius was no king's son and he was not reared and educated in sumptuous luxury. When he came to power, having taken control as one of a group of seven, he divided the kingdom into seven parts, small traces of which remain to this day. He thought it best to administer the kingdom by passing laws introducing some social equality, and he fixed, by law, the tribute money that Cyrus had promised to the Persians, thus ensuring friendship and fellow-feeling among all the Persians

by winning the Persian people over with generous gifts. Consequently, his armies were so full of goodwill that they won as much territory for him as Cyrus had originally left to him.

695e

Athenian: After Darius came Xerxes, who had, once again, received a pampered royal education. We could quite justifiably say to Darius, “O Darius, because you did not learn from Cyrus’ mistake, you trained Xerxes in the very same habits that Cyrus taught to Cambyses.” Anyway, since he was a product of the very same education, Xerxes ended up suffering more or less the same fate as Cambyses. And since then there has hardly been a single king among the Persians who has been truly great in anything more than name. And what is responsible for this, according to my argument, is not ill-fortune, but the bad life that is for the most part lived by the children of exceptionally wealthy folk and tyrants. In fact, no child or man, old or young, could ever attain an exceptional level of excellence from such an upbringing as this. These, then, are issues which, we maintain, the lawgiver should take into consideration and we should do the same right now. Well, it is only right, my Spartan friends, to grant your city this much at least: you do not assign any special honour or training to rich or poor, king or commoner, beyond the prophetic directions you were given at first by some god. In fact, pre-eminent civic honours should not be conferred just because someone is especially wealthy, no more than we should do so just because the person is swift or pretty or strong, unless he has some excellence, and even the excellence should include sound-mindedness.

696a

Megillus: What do you mean by this, stranger?

696b

Athenian: Courage is presumably one part of excellence?

Megillus: Of course.

Athenian: Well then, listen to the argument and decide this for yourself. Would you choose someone who was extremely courageous, but devoid of sound-mindedness and restraint, as your housemate or neighbour?

Megillus: What a suggestion!

Athenian: What about someone who has a skill and is wise in that sense, but unjust?

Megillus: Not at all.

Athenian: And yet justice does not flourish without sound-mindedness.

Clinias: No, how could it?

696c

Athenian: Nor indeed does the wisdom we described a while ago of the person whose pleasures and pains are in accord with and adhere to correct reasoning.

Megillus: Indeed, it does not.

Athenian: There is a further point we should consider on the issue of civic honours, and what sort are correctly or incorrectly conferred on any occasion.

Megillus: What point?

Athenian: Would sound-mindedness, present in a soul on its own without any other excellence, be honourable or dishonourable, rightly speaking?

Megillus: I don't know how to answer you.

Athenian: And yet, you have responded quite reasonably. In fact, had you chosen either of the two alternatives, you would, in my opinion anyway, have gone awry.

Megillus: So my answer has turned out quite well.

696d

Athenian: Indeed. It is not worth saying anything about this additional element in the honourable and dishonourable. Mute silence is a better option.

Megillus: I presume you mean that sound-mindedness is the additional element.

Athenian: Yes. And whatever benefits us most, when combined with this additional element, would rightly be honoured most. The second most beneficial would be honoured second. And if each successive benefit was given its place in the sequence of honours in this way, that would be the right way to arrange them.

Megillus: Quite so.

697a

Athenian: Well then, shouldn't we also say that it is once again the role of the legislator to assign these?

Megillus: Very much so.

Athenian: Would you like, then, to leave it to him to deal with them all, each individual task and all the details, while we, aspiring to be men of the law, make a threefold division in an effort to distinguish separately between those that are most significant, and those that are in second or third place?

Megillus: Yes, certainly.

697b

Athenian: So, we are saying, it seems, that a city that is to save itself and be as happy as humanly possible must, of necessity, assign honours and their opposites in the correct manner. It is only right that the goods of the soul occupy the first and most honoured position, provided the soul is possessed of sound-mindedness. In second place are the goods and beauties of the body, and third are the so-called goods associated with property and wealth. Any lawgiver or city that goes outside of

those rankings by elevating wealth to a position of honour, or promoting any of the lesser benefits to a higher status in terms of honour, is performing an unholy and unstatesmanlike act. May we say this or what should we say?

Megillus: We may say this, plainly.

697c

Athenian: Although our investigation of the political system of the Persians made us say all this at such length, we still find that they ended up in an even worse predicament. The reason for this, according to us, was that they restricted the freedom of the populace excessively, introduced more subservience than appropriate, and thus they undid the friendship and communal spirit of their city. And once this is gone, the policy of the rulers is no longer framed in the interests of their subjects and the populace, but in the interests of their own authority. If they ever think it will be to their own advantage, even slightly, they devastate whole cities, and friendly peoples too, by destroying them with fire, and so they are hated, relentlessly and mercilessly, and they return that hatred. And when they need the populace to fight for them, they find there is no communal spirit among them, no willingness to do battle eagerly in the face of danger. So although in theory they have a vast population at their disposal, they are all useless in a war, so they hire people in as though they were in short supply, believing that their safety lies in foreign mercenaries. As well as this, they inevitably show their ignorance by proclaiming, through their own actions, that everything the city calls honourable and good is a mere trifle in comparison with gold and silver.

Megillus: Entirely so.

698a

Athenian: Well, let that be the end of our discussion of the Persians and how badly their affairs are managed nowadays because of their extreme subservience and authoritarianism.

Megillus: Certainly.

698b

Athenian: Next we should describe the Attic political system in the same way, showing that total freedom, without any rulers, is far worse than the regulated authority of others. Indeed, at the time of the Persian advance upon the Greeks, or perhaps upon more or less all the inhabitants of Europe, we had a political system of ancient date with positions of authority based upon four valuations. Reverence was present among us as a queen, and because of her we were willing to live in subservience to the laws of the time. What's more, the sheer magnitude of the horde that came by land and by sea struck us with fear and perplexity, and increased our subservience to our rulers and our laws to an even greater extent. As a result of all this, a strong bond of affection developed among ourselves. Indeed, some ten years before the battle of Salamis, Datis arrived, leading a Persian horde. He had been sent by Darius with explicit orders directed against the Athenians and Eretrians.⁴⁷ He was to enslave them and deport them, and his own death was the penalty for failure. Datis did not take long to completely overpower the Eretrians with his vast army, and he sent a frightening message to our city, Athens, that not a single Eretrian had escaped him. In fact, Datis' soldiers, with joined hands, had swept through the whole territory of Eretria like a dragnet. This account, whatever its source, whether true or false, terrified the other Greeks, and especially the Athenians, and no one except the Spartans was willing to help them when they sent embassies everywhere. But because their war against Messene was ongoing at the time, and perhaps because they were delayed by something else we don't know about, the Spartans arrived one day late for the battle of Marathon. After this, reports of large-scale preparations and endless threats kept reaching us from the king. Eventually we were told that Darius had died, and his son, who had inherited the throne, was

young and energetic and had no intentions of giving up on the invasion plan. The Athenians presumed that all these preparations were directed against themselves because of what happened at Marathon, and when they heard that a canal had been dug at Athos, that the Hellespont had been bridged, and of the huge number of ships in the Persian fleet, they decided that they would be safe neither by land nor by sea. They realised that no one would help them, for they remembered that when the Persians invaded previously and were successful in Eretria, no one came to their aid, nor did anyone run the risk of fighting alongside them. So they were expecting the same thing to happen again this time, by land anyway, and they lost all hope of safety by sea when they saw a thousand Persian ships, or even more, bearing down upon them. It occurred to them that there was only one safe course, slender and perilous, but the only one. They looked back at what happened previously, and how, from the bleak situation that they also faced then, military victory appeared to emerge. Uplifted by this hope, they discovered that their own refuge lay in themselves alone, and in the gods. A number of factors combined to engender a feeling of friendship among them. One was a fear born of their perilous circumstances at the time, while another originated in the ancient laws, a fear they had acquired through their subservience to those laws of old. We have often referred to this fear in our earlier discussions as ‘reverence’, and we said that anyone who is to be a good person should be subject to this. But the coward is free of reverence and does not experience it, and unless such people had been seized by terror at the time, they would never have joined the defensive effort to protect their temples, tombs and fatherland, their family and friends, by helping as they did on that occasion. We would rather have been routed then, and all of us scattered this way and that.

699c

Megillus: Very much so, stranger, what you have said is correct and a great credit to yourself and your fatherland.

699d

Athenian: Quite so, Megillus, and it is only right to recount the events of that age to you, since you have inherited the character of your forefathers. Now, you and Clinias should consider whether we are saying anything that is relevant to law-making. For I am not telling these stories for their own sake, but for the sake of the topic I am discussing. Yes, look, the same thing, somehow, happened to ourselves as happened to the Persians, except that they totally subjugated the populace, while we, in contrast, urged the masses in the direction of total freedom. So, what should we say next, and how should we express it, since our previous arguments have in a way been quite well stated?

Megillus: Good point, but please try to explain what you are saying to us a bit more clearly.

699e

Athenian: I will. Under our ancient laws, my friends, the populace was not the master. The populace was rather, in a sense, willingly subject to the laws.

700a

Megillus: To what sort of laws?

Athenian: Firstly, to the laws concerning the music of that era. Let's look there so that we may describe, from the beginning, the development of this excessively free lifestyle. At the time, our music was in fact divided into various forms and structures. One was a form of song consisting of prayers to the gods, which were called hymns. Another form of song, almost the opposite of this, consisted of what are best called dirges, and there was another consisting of paeans, and one more which is called a dithyramb,⁴⁸ which is about the birth of Dionysus, I think. Nomes were given this particular name as being a different kind of song,⁴⁹ which they said was for the cithara. Once these and

some others had been duly set in order, it was not permitted to apply one form of melody to another form. The ultimate authority to understand these principles, and indeed pass judgement and impose penalties upon those who transgressed them, did not lie, as it does nowadays, with the trumpeting and uncouth clamouring of the multitude, nor their approving applause. The educated folk themselves agreed to listen in silence to the very end, while for children, their attendants and the common crowd, the rod of chastisement kept them in order. So in these matters, the majority of the citizens accepted such regulation and authority, and did not dare to pass judgement by clamouring. After this, with the passage of time, poets arose who were responsible for an unmusical lawlessness, and although they were poetical by nature, they did not understand what was right and lawful in the realm of the Muses. Frenzied, and much in the grip of pleasure, they mixed dirges with hymns, paeans with dithyrambs, and even imitated the sound of flutes on the cithara. By combining everything with everything, they, in their ignorance, unintentionally perpetuated the false notion that there is no such thing as correctness in music, and that it is quite alright to pass judgement based upon the pleasure it affords to whomever enjoys it, regardless of whether that person is good or bad. By composing works of this sort and adding words of a similar sort, they instilled musical lawlessness into most of the people and the audacity to believe that they were themselves competent judges. And so, the spectators became noisy folk rather than a quiet people, as though they themselves understood what was good and bad in the realm of music, and so instead of the rule by the best, a degenerate rule by the spectators arose. Now, if a democracy of free men had arisen in music alone that would not have been a particularly serious development. But our current notion that everyone is wise about everything began with music, as did lawlessness, and following close behind them came liberty, for believing that

they knew so much, they had no fear, and their lack of fear begat an absence of shame, for it is surely shamelessness of the lowest order not to fear the opinion of the best because of an impudence born of excessive liberty.

Megillus: Very true.

701b

Athenian: Next, after this freedom comes another, which is an unwillingness to be subservient to rulers, and after this comes a flight from any subservience to, or correction by, father, mother or elders. As the end approaches, they have an urge to pay no heed to any laws, and finally, towards the very end of the process, they disregard oaths, entreaties, and anything to do with the gods, as they display and imitate the fabled ancient nature of Titans.⁵⁰ And reverting once more to the same conditions as those fellows, they usher in a harsh age of unrelenting evils. Well, what again is the point of saying all this? Apparently I should restrain the argument from time to time and not allow myself to be borne along by the force of the argument, like a horse with no bridle in its mouth, and, as the saying goes, “fall off my donkey”. So I repeat the question once more. What is the point of saying all this?

Megillus: Good question.

701d

Athenian: The point relates to what was said previously.

Megillus: Which was?

Athenian: We said that the lawgiver should frame laws with three aims in view: that the city under his laws will be free, friendly towards itself, and possessed of reason. These were the aims, were they not?

Megillus: Certainly.

701e

Athenian: With these aims in view, we picked the most authoritarian system of government and the one that allowed most freedom, and we are now considering which of these two is governed in the correct manner. Taking a moderate example of each of these, of authoritarianism on the one hand and of freedom on the other, we saw that everything went exceptionally well for them in each case. But when they went on to the extreme, either of subservience in one case or its opposite in the other, there was no benefit to either of them.

Megillus: Very true.

702a

Athenian: And, indeed, for the same reasons we looked at the settlement of the Dorian horde, the settlement of Dardanos in the foothills, the maritime settlement too, and indeed the first people who survived the deluge, in addition to our previous discussions about music and drinking and the topics prior to these. All this was said for the same reason, in order to see clearly how exactly a city may best be governed and, in the case of an individual, how he may best live his own life. But have we achieved anything worthwhile? What test for ourselves may we suggest, Megillus and Clinias?

702b

Clinias: I think I have one, stranger. It seems that a certain providence has governed these arguments we have just gone through. For I was at a stage where I was in need of these, and your arrival, along with Megillus here, was most opportune. I shan't conceal my present predicament from you two, in fact I regard your presence as an omen. For most of Crete is engaged in forming a colony, and the people of Cnossus have been put in charge of the process, and their city has assigned the task to myself and nine others. At the same time they directed us to frame laws based upon any local laws that we approved of, and any laws from elsewhere that in our view were best, regardless

of the fact that they were foreign. So let's do this favour to myself and to yourselves. Let's construct a city, in words, as though we were founding it from the very beginning, by drawing upon what we have said so far. At the same time, this will also constitute our enquiry into the topic we are investigating, and, what's more, I may find this process useful for my future city.

702d

Athenian: Well Clinias, that's not a declaration of war, so if Megillus has no objection, you may presume that as far as I am concerned you can count on my fullest possible cooperation.

Clinias: Well said.

Megillus: And the same goes for me.

702e

Clinias: Thank you both. So let's first try to found our city in words.

BOOK IV

704a

Athenian: Come on then, what precisely should we suppose our city will be? When I say this, I am not asking what name it has at present or what it should be called in future, since that might well be determined by the circumstances of its foundation, or by the region it is in, or the name of some river or spring or of one of the gods of that region might be applied to the newly founded city. Rather, in the case of the city, what I really want to ask is whether it will be on the coast or inland.

Clinias: Well, stranger, the city I have just been referring to is about eighty stades⁵¹ or thereabouts from the coast.

Athenian: What about harbours? Are there any on that side of the coast or does it have no harbour at all?

Clinias: On that side, stranger, it is well provided with harbours. As good as any.

704c

Athenian: Oh dear! What about the surrounding countryside? Does the land produce all your needs, or are there some needs that cannot be met?

Clinias: It is not really deficient in anything.

Athenian: Will it have a neighbouring city close by?

Clinias: No, not really, that's why it is being founded. Emigration from the locality of old has left the land deserted for quite some time.

Athenian: What about mountains, plains and forests? What proportion of each does it have?

Clinias: It is much the same as the rest of Crete generally.

Athenian: Are you saying that it is rough terrain rather than flat?

704d

Clinias: Certainly.

Athenian: Then, when it comes to the acquisition of excellence, at least it would not be beyond remedy. For if the city was to be on the coast with a good harbour and did not produce all that was needed but had many needs that it could not meet, some mighty saviour would have been required, and some divine lawgivers too, if it were not to have a huge variety of depraved habits as a natural consequence. At the moment, those eighty stades afford some comfort. Yet, it is situated closer to the sea than it should be, and, more to the point, you say it has good harbours, but even this is acceptable. Indeed, having the sea close by makes everyday life pleasant, and yet it really is a "briny and bitter neighbour"⁵² since it fills a city with commercial activity and retail business, breeds restless and

distrustful traits in people's souls, and makes the city suspicious and unkind towards itself and towards the rest of humanity too. In the face of this, there is of course some consolation in the fact that it produces all that it needs, but because the territory is rugged it obviously would not produce everything that is needed, and a surplus besides. For if it had a surplus it would be able to export a great deal, gold and silver coin would fill its coffers in return, and in a way, all things considered, there is no greater enemy than this to the development of a just and noble character, as we said earlier, if you recall the discussion.

Clinias: Yes, we remember. And we agree now, as we did then, that it is correct.

705c

Athenian: Well, what about this? How well is this region of our country supplied with wood for shipbuilding?

Clinias: There isn't any fir or pine worth mentioning, nor is there much cypress either. What's more, you would find very little larch or plane, which shipbuilders regularly need to use for ships' interiors.

Athenian: That, again, would not be a bad feature of the country.

Clinias: How so?

705d

Athenian: It is good that a city is unable to imitate its enemies too easily when the behaviour to be imitated is base.

Clinias: What makes you say this? Is it something we said earlier?

Athenian: Well, my divine friend, keep an eye on me in view of what was said at the outset about the laws of Crete, that they should have a single aim in view. Now, the two of you said that this aim was military, but I responded by saying that although it

is all very well that such regulations should look to excellence, I did not accept at all that they would look to a part of excellence and not to the entire. So the two of you should now watch over me, in turn, in my current legislative efforts in case I enact a law that is not directed towards excellence or to a part of excellence. For I am proposing that a law is rightly enacted only when it aims every time, like an archer, at an outcome that is always constantly accompanied by something ever beautiful, and at that alone. All else should be set aside, be it wealth or anything else of that sort, in the absence of the stated aims.

705e

Athenian: Now, the base imitation of one's enemies that I spoke of earlier arises in the following way when people dwell close to the sea and are troubled by enemies. For instance – and I am not criticising your people, Clinias – Minos once imposed a cruel tribute to be paid by the inhabitants of Attica when he had acquired enormous maritime supremacy,⁵³ while the others had, as yet, no ships fit for war, unlike nowadays. Nor indeed did their territory have lots of wood for shipbuilding so that they could readily provide themselves with a naval force. So they were not immediately able to defend themselves against their enemies by imitating Cretan seamanship and becoming mariners themselves. Indeed, it would have been even better for them to lose many times seven youths and remain as staunch foot soldiers rather than becoming mariners, who repeatedly jump from their ships and then rush back on board once more, who dare not stand their ground and face death when the enemy is bearing down on them, and see nothing shameful in that. Rather, since they always have plausible excuses, they are quite ready to cast their weapons aside and take flight in what they call retreats without dishonour. This sort of talk is inclined to arise as a consequence of resorting to naval warfare, and it merits not unbounded praise but the exact

opposite, for degenerate behaviour should never become habitual, especially in the very best class of our citizens. We could also learn from Homer, I presume, that a practice of this sort is not noble. For he has Odysseus upbraid Agamemnon for ordering the ships to be dragged down to the water's edge when the Achaeans are being pressed hard by the Trojans. Odysseus gets angry with him and says:

*...you who in the very closing of clamorous battle
tell us to haul our strong-benched ships to the sea so that even
more glory may befall the Trojans, who beat us already,
and headlong destruction swing our way, since the Achaeans
will not hold their battle as the ships are being hauled seaward,
but will look about and let go the exultation of fighting.
There, O leader of the people, your plan will be ruin.⁵⁴*

So Homer, too, recognised the fact that placing triremes at sea in support of soldiers fighting on land is bad practice. Even lions would get used to fleeing from deer if they cultivated habits of this sort. What is more, when the power of cities derives from their navies, the honours, when they are saved, are not bestowed upon the most deserving members of their fighting force. For their safety derives from the skill of the steersman, the captain and the oarsman, and a whole variety of people who are not of much consequence, and so it is not possible for someone to confer honours on each deserving person in the correct manner. Yet, in the absence of this ability, how could a city still prosper?

Clinias: It is scarcely possible. But, stranger, it was the naval battle of Salamis, fought by Greeks against the barbarians, which, according to us Cretans anyway, saved Greece.

707c

Athenian: Yes indeed, that is what most Greeks say, and most barbarians too. But we, my friend – that is, Megillus here and I – maintain that the land battle that took place at Marathon was what saved the Greeks initially, while the one at Plataea completed the process,⁵⁵ and while these battles made better people of the Greeks, the other battles did not, which is a strange way to speak of battles that saved us at the time, for I am now including the naval battle at Artemisium for you, in addition to the one at Salamis. As a matter of fact, in looking now at the excellence of a political system, and the nature of a territory, we are also considering the arrangement of the law. Unlike most people, we do not regard the mere survival and continued existence of people as the most important issue, but becoming as good as they possibly can, and being so for as long as they live. But I think we actually said this before in our previous discussions.

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: Then we should consider this question alone, whether we are adopting the same approach as we did previously, the one that is best for cities in relation to their foundation and law-making.

Clinias: Very much so.

707e

Athenian: Then tell me next, what people will you be settling? Will there be people from all over Crete, anyone who wants to come, because the population in the various cities has exceeded what the land can sustain? For you are not, I suppose, inviting any Greek who wishes to join you, even though I can see that some people from Argos, Aegina and elsewhere in Greece have settled in your country. So tell me, in this case, where do you say that the current body of citizens will come from?

708a

Clinias: They are likely to come from all over Crete, and as for the rest of the Greeks, it seems that settlers from the Peloponnese are made most welcome. And, indeed, what you were just saying is true, some are from Argos, and of those who are here at present, the most highly regarded clan, the Gortynian, is a colony from Gortyn on the Peloponnese.

708b

Athenian: Well, a settlement would not be easy for the cities unless it is formed, like a swarm of bees, from a single clan coming from a single territory, a friend coming from friends, under pressure because of some shortage of land, or driven by some other afflictions of this sort. There are times too when part of a city may be compelled to relocate elsewhere, having been forced to do so by civil strife, and in one case a whole city went into exile, having been totally overpowered by an overwhelming onslaught. Now, to settle all these and legislate for them is easy in one sense, but difficult in another. For the existence of a single people, with the same language and laws, leads to a spirit of friendship because they share the same sacred rituals and everything else of that sort. However, they do not readily accept laws and other civic arrangements that are different from those of their homeland, and sometimes, although the degeneracy of their laws caused civil strife, they still seek, through force of habit, to behave in exactly the same way that led to their downfall previously, and they become disobedient and difficult for the founders and legislators to deal with. In contrast, a people that combines all sorts of differences might perhaps be more inclined to submit to new laws, but for them to live and breathe in unison, like the team of horses in the proverb, would take much more time and be a huge challenge. The fact of the matter is that making laws and founding cities is, for men, the ultimate test of excellence.

Clinias: Quite likely, but please explain more clearly what you have in mind when you say all this.

Athenian: My good man, as I return again to considering lawmakers, it is possible that I will, at the same time, say something that is actually derogatory, but as long as I say something relevant, this should not really be a problem. But why am I troubled at all? In almost all human undertakings, the situation is much the same.

Clinias: What are you referring to?

708e

Athenian: I was about to say that no human being ever institutes any laws at all, but all sorts of chance occurrences and various coincidences institute all the laws for us. For some, war may perhaps overthrow the political system by force and change the laws, or the challenge of grinding poverty may do so. Diseases, too, force us to make lots of innovations when we are afflicted by plague, or when unseasonal weather lasts for many years as often happens. Anyone, in view of all this, might be justified in saying, as I did just now, that no mortal creature institutes any laws whatsoever, and almost all human affairs are a matter of chance. And although it seems right to say all this about navigation, helmsmanship, medicine and generalship, there is, in fact, something further to be said in these same cases, with similar justification.

Clinias: Which is?

709b

Athenian: That God is all, and that chance and opportunity, with the help of God, determine the course of all the affairs of humanity. And yet we should accept that these are accompanied by a third more gentle element – skill. For I myself would suggest that in a storm it would be a huge advantage for the steersman to cooperate with opportunity. Is this so?

Clinias: Quite so.

709c

Athenian: And the same argument would apply, in like manner, in the other cases too, and indeed the same point should be conceded in the case of legislation. Once the other conditions that the country requires, if it is ever to be settled in a goodly manner, are in place, then a lawgiver who holds to the truth is needed by such a city, to help them.

Clinias: Very true.

Athenian: Now, wouldn't a person who possessed the skill involved in any of the areas I mentioned also presumably be able to pray, in the right way, for whatever he needed, through the operation of chance, so that his skill alone would suffice?

Clinias: He would, indeed.

709d

Athenian: And all the other skilled people we referred to could tell us what their own prayer would be for, if we asked them. Is this so?

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: And the lawgiver will, I presume, also do the same thing.

Clinias: Presumably.

Athenian: Let us address him as follows: "Come on then, lawgiver, what should we give you, what condition should the city be in, so that you will be able to proceed from there, and be competent, by yourself, to manage the city?"

Clinias: So, what's the right thing to say in response?

Athenian: We shall give the lawgiver's response, isn't this so?

Clinias: Yes.

Athenian: “Give me a city under tyrannical rule,” he will say, “and let the tyrant be young, with a good memory, a quick learner, courageous, and possessed of natural greatness. And if these various qualities, present in the tyrannical soul, are to be of any benefit, let them be accompanied now by something else, which, as we said previously, needs to accompany all the parts of excellence.”

Clinias: Megillus, I presume that the stranger is saying that what needs to accompany the others is sound-mindedness. Is this so, stranger?

710a

Athenian: Yes, the commonplace sound-mindedness, Clinias, not what someone might speak of when they get too serious and argue that sound-mindedness must be the same as wisdom. It is an innate quality which shows immediately in children and in animals, that some have no control when it comes to pleasures, while others have control. And we said that in isolation from the various other goods we are discussing, it is of no account. I presume you get my meaning.

Clinias: Yes, certainly.

710b

Athenian: Then our tyrant should possess this, in addition to those other natural qualities, if a city is to attain, in the quickest and best way possible, the political system it needs in order to live its life in happiness. For there is not, nor could there ever be, a quicker or better way of establishing a political system than this.

710c

Clinias: How, stranger, and by what argument, could anyone convince themselves that they are speaking correctly if they say this?

Athenian: Presumably, Clinias, it is easy enough to discern this much at least, that this is the natural state of affairs.

Clinias: How do you mean? Are you saying it happens when a tyrant arises who is young, sound-minded, learns easily, has a good memory, is courageous and is possessed of natural greatness?

710d

Athenian: You should add good fortune, in one respect only, that a praiseworthy lawgiver would also arise at the time, and that fortune would bring them both together. For with this arrangement in place, God has done almost all he ever does when he wants a city to do exceptionally well. The second-best arrangement would involve two rulers of this sort, and so on for third best, and, in general, the more there are, the worse the arrangement, and the fewer there are, the better.

Clinias: You maintain that the best city arises, apparently, from a tyranny involving a lawgiver of the highest rate, and a tyrant of good character. You say that it would be easiest and quickest to effect the change to the best city from such an arrangement. From an oligarchy it is second easiest, is that your meaning? And from a democracy you think it is third easiest?

710e

Athenian: Not at all, no, first and easiest is from a tyranny, second is from a political system based upon kingship, third is from some sort of democracy. Oligarchy comes fourth, and because there are so many powerful factions within it, it would face enormous difficulty in allowing the best city to come into existence. And we say, in fact, that this comes about when a true lawgiver naturally arises who happens to share some power with the most influential people in the city. And when this element is fewest in number and greatest in power, as in a tyranny, then the change tends to occur quickly and easily.

Clinias: How so? We don't really understand you.

711a

Athenian: And yet, this has been said, I believe, not once but many times. But perhaps you and Megillus have never seen a city under tyrannical rule.

Clinias: Nor have I any particular desire to see one.

711b

Athenian: And yet you would see the very feature I am now referring to in this.

Clinias: Which is?

Athenian: A tyrant who wishes to change the habits of a city does not require great exertions or a lot of time. He first needs to proceed in that direction himself. Whether he wishes to turn the citizens towards activities involving excellence, or in the opposite direction, he himself should be the standard of all action, conferring praise and honour on some while censuring others, and showing no respect for anyone who remains unpersuaded in any field of endeavour.

711c

Clinias: Yes, but why do we believe that the other citizens will so quickly follow the lead of someone who has adopted this combination of persuasion and force?

Athenian: Let no one persuade us, my friends, that a city could ever change its laws more quickly and easily than through the personal leadership of its powerful people. There is no other way to do this now, nor will there ever be. And, indeed, this is not an impossibility for us, nor would it be difficult. No, the difficulty lies elsewhere, in the occurrence of something that happens only rarely in history, yet whenever it does happen it brings countless advantages of all sorts to the city in which it occurs.

Clinias: What are you referring to?

711d

Athenian: This happens whenever a divine passion for sound-minded and just action arises in some people who wield great power, whether ruling monarchically or on the basis of the exceptional pre-eminence of their wealth or family. Or someone might even hark back to the character of Nestor,⁵⁶ who is said to have excelled everyone else in his power of speech, and to have surpassed them even more in sound-mindedness. Now, although this happened, so they say, in Trojan times, it has not happened at all in our own. But if such a person has existed, or will exist, or one of us is such a person, he himself lives a blessed life, and blessed are those who hear the sound-minded words that flow from his mouth. And the same argument applies to power in general. Whenever the greatest power coincides in a person with wisdom and sound-mindedness, the best of political systems, and of laws too, arise naturally. Otherwise this never happens.⁵⁷ So let us take all this as a story, oracular in nature, which demonstrates that although it is difficult for a city with good laws to arise, it would be the quickest and easiest development of all if what we are describing were to happen.

Clinias: How so?

712a

Athenian: Why don't we apply this to your city and attempt, like elderly boys, to fashion its laws in discussion.

Clinias: Let's proceed without further delay.

Athenian: Let us then invoke God's presence at the establishment of our city, that he may hear our prayer, come to us with gracious goodwill, and join us in ordering the city and its laws.

Clinias: Yes, let him come.

Athenian: But what precise political system do we intend to impose upon our city?

712b

Clinias: What exactly do you mean? Please explain more clearly. Are you asking if it will be a democracy, or an oligarchy, or an aristocracy, or a kingship, since presumably you could not mean a tyranny. At least Megillus and I don't think so.

712c

Athenian: Well, come on then, which of you would like to answer first and say, in the case of your own political system, which of these types it is?

Megillus: In that case, since I am the eldest, isn't it only right that I speak first?

Clinias: Perhaps so.

712d

Megillus: In fact, stranger, now that I think about the Spartan political system, I am quite unable to say offhand what it should be called. In fact, it seems to me to resemble a tyranny, since the provision for ephors that it contains is surprisingly tyrannical, yet sometimes it strikes me as the most democratically governed city of them all. Then again, it would be most odd to deny that it is an aristocracy, and indeed it includes life-long kingship, the most ancient of all according to ourselves and all mankind. So when I am suddenly asked the question, just like that, I am actually unable, as I said, to say definitively which of these political systems it is.

Clinias: It looks as if I am in the same predicament as you are, Megillus. For I have considerable difficulty in saying for certain that the political system in Cnossus is any one of these.

713a

Athenian: That, best of men, is because you really do share political systems, whereas what we named just now are not

political systems but city managements, dominated and enslaved by parts of themselves, each being named after the dominant element. But if your city really must be named after something like this, it should be called after the god who is truly the master of those who possess reason.

Clinias: What god is that?

Athenian: Well, if we are somehow to give a satisfactory answer to your question, may we make a little more use of storytelling?

Clinias: Is that the way we need to do this?

713b

Athenian: It certainly is, for long before the settlement of the cities we have described, they say that in the time of Cronus there had been a government and management, and a very happy one too, and that any of the best managed states nowadays are an imitation of this.

Clinias: It seems then that we really need to hear about it.

Athenian: Well, that is my view too. That is why I introduced this into our discussions.

713c

Clinias: And you were quite right to do so, and since the story is so relevant it's only right that you should recount the whole thing.

Athenian: I must do as you say then. Well, we have received the traditional account of the blessed life enjoyed by those who lived then, and how they had everything in abundance and without effort. The explanation for all this, we are told, was as follows: Cronus recognised, of course, that, as we have explained, human nature is not up to the task of independently managing all human affairs without becoming full of arrogance and injustice. So with this in mind, he then installed kings for our cities, and rulers who were not human but belonged rather

to a more divine and exalted race, the race of daimons. This is just what we ourselves do nowadays with our sheep and herds of domestic animals. We do not make oxen rule over oxen or goats over goats, but we ourselves, a kind superior to them, act as their masters. In like manner, the god, out of love for humanity, appointed a kind superior to us, the daimons, to take care of us. This was a very easy task for them and a great kindness to us, providing us with peace and respect, lawfulness and unrestricted justice, and ensuring that the various groups that comprise humanity were free from faction and happy.

714a

Athenian: This account, then, is now saying – and what it is saying is true – that any cities ruled by some mortal and not by the god find no escape from evils and hardships for their citizens. It would have us believe that we should imitate by every possible means the life of the age of Cronus as described, and manage our homes and our cities while obeying the immortal element within us in our personal and public lives, and calling regulation, by reason, ‘law’. But what if one person, or some oligarchy, or indeed a democracy, were possessed of a soul that hungers for pleasures and passions, and needs to be filled with these, a soul that resists nothing and is assailed by unending, insatiate evil diseases? Well, if something of this sort, having trampled all over the laws, rules a city or some individual, then there is no way to save it. We should consider this account, Clinias, and decide whether we are to be persuaded by this, or what we should do.

Clinias: We are to be persuaded, of course, necessarily.

714c

Athenian: Now, are you aware that some people maintain that there are as many forms of laws as there are political systems, and we have already listed the systems of government as popularly described? Please do not presume that the issue

involved here is unimportant; it is of the utmost importance, for this question faces us once again: where lies the standard of what is just and what is unjust? For these people maintain that the laws should not look to warfare as their standard, nor indeed to excellence as a whole, but to the established political system, whatever that may be, and to the interest of that system so that it may govern forever and never be dissolved. And the natural definition of justice is best formulated in this way.

Clinias: How?

Athenian: That justice is the interest of the more powerful.

714d

Clinias: Explain this more clearly, please.

Athenian: In this way: the powerful, they say, always of course enact the city's laws. Is this so?

Clinias: True.

Athenian: Well then, do you think, as they maintain, that the general populace, or some other political system, or indeed a tyrant when triumphant, would willingly enact laws with any other primary aim besides its own interest in maintaining its authority?

Clinias: No, of course not.

714e

Athenian: And whoever enacts these refers to the enactments as just, and will punish the person who transgresses them for acting unjustly.

Clinias: Yes, quite likely.

Athenian: So such enactments would always, in this way and on this basis, constitute justice.

Clinias: According to this argument anyway.

Athenian: Yes, this is one of those rights of government.

Clinias: What rights?

Athenian: Those we considered before, concerning who should have authority over whom. And it was evident that parents should have authority over their offspring, the elder over the younger, the noble over the ignoble, and there were, if you recall, many other cases too of various restrictions on mutual authority. And, indeed, one of the rights was this very one; we said that Pindar takes the extreme of violence as natural justice, as he puts it.

Clinias: Yes, that's what was said at the time.

715a

Athenian: Then, consider this. To which of these are we to entrust our city? For this sort of thing has occurred thousands of times before, in various cities.

Clinias: What sort of thing?

Athenian: When there has been a fight over positions of authority, the victors take over the affairs of the city so comprehensively that they concede no authority whatsoever to those who lost out, or even to their descendants. The two sides spend their time watching one another in case someone who remembers the evil events of the past assumes office in an uprising. Of course, we are now denying that these circumstances constitute political systems, or that any laws are correct unless they are enacted for the sake of the entire community of the city. Those who pass laws in the interest of some people and not others are, according to us, not citizens but members of factions, and their insistence that these laws are just is a vain claim. We are saying all this for the following reason. We shall not appoint anyone to any position of authority in your city because he is wealthy or because of some other acquisition of that sort, such as strength or stature or family. But we maintain that the person who is entirely

obedient to the established laws, and is triumphant in the city in that sense, should be given the most important role, the service of the gods. So, the most important role goes to the first, the second most important to whomever comes second in the contest, and each of the other positions of authority should be given, in due order, to whomever comes next.

715d

Athenian: Those who are referred to as rulers I have now called ‘servants of the law’, not for the sake of verbal innovation, but because I believe that the salvation or perdition of the city hinges, most of all, upon this. For when law is subservient and devoid of authority, I see destruction close at hand for such a city. But when law is the master of those in authority, and the rulers are subservient to the law, then I behold salvation, and everything good that the gods ever bestow upon cities.

Clinias: Yes, by Zeus, stranger, you have the keen sight appropriate to your age.

715e

Athenian: Indeed so. When people are young they generally have extremely poor sight when it comes to this sort of thing, but in old age it’s at its sharpest.

Clinias: Very true.

Athenian: Well, what next? May we not presume that our colonists are here and are present, and that the rest of our address to them should be concluded?

Clinias: Yes, why not?

Athenian: Well, let us address them as follows: “O men, according to the ancient tradition, God, holding the beginning, end and middle of all of the things that are, proceeds without deviation along nature’s circular course. Justice always accompanies him and is the punisher of those who depart from his divine law. So anyone who intends to be happy holds to

justice and follows her in humility and good order, while anyone who gets carried away by pride, or excited over wealth or honours or a pretty body, inflames his soul with arrogance through impetuosity combined with stupidity. He then feels the need neither for a ruler nor for a leader; he believes he is competent to lead others, and he is left alone, forsaken by God, and having been forsaken, he co-opts others who are like himself, behaves erratically and causes all sorts of confusion. To many people he seems to be someone significant, but he very soon pays the deserved penalty to justice, and brings utter ruination upon himself, his household and his city. Now, since these matters have been ordained in this way, what should an intelligent person do, what should his resolution be, and what should he avoid?"

Clinias: Well, this much at least is obvious; every man should resolve to be included among those who follow after God.

716c

Athenian: "So, what conduct is dear to and follows after God? There is one, and there is an ancient account of this which says that like is dear to like,⁵⁸ once there is due measure, while things that are unmeasured are dear neither to themselves nor to the measured. Now, for us, God more than anything else would be the measure of all things, much more so than any 'man' that some refer to.⁵⁹ And someone who is to be dear to such a being as this needs to become like this himself, to the very best of his ability. And so, by this argument, he among us who is sound-minded is dear to God for he is like God, and he who is not sound-minded is unlike Him and at variance with Him, and so too is the unjust man, and the same argument also applies in general."

716d

Athenian: "Now, there is another principle that follows from all these, and in my view it is the most exalted and truest principle

of all: that, for the good person, to sacrifice to the gods and to commune with them constantly through prayers, offerings and every possible service of gods is the noblest, the best, and the most effective way to a happy life, and the most appropriate by far. But for the bad person, the very opposite is naturally the case, for he is impure of soul, while the good person is pure, and it is never right for a good man or god to receive gifts from the defiled. So, for the unholy, any great endeavour in relation to the gods is in vain, but for all those who are holy, it is always opportune. So this is the mark at which we should aim, but what are the missiles, so called, that should most correctly be fired, and from what bow should we fire them? Firstly, we maintain that someone intent upon piety would rightly hit the mark if he bestowed honours upon the gods of the earth, after honouring the Olympian gods and those that hold the city, thus bestowing the odd, the second, and the left-handed upon the gods of the earth, and the opposites of these, the superior, upon the other gods we just mentioned.⁶⁰ After these gods, the wise would worship the daimons, and after these, the heroes, and close behind these, private shrines to ancestral gods, worshipped according to law. Then come the honours due to living parents, as it is proper that a debtor should repay the first and greatest of debts, the most ancient of all obligations. He should believe that whatever he has and holds, all belongs to those who gave him birth and reared him, and should be used to serve those people to the utmost of his ability, firstly with his wealth, secondly with his body, and thirdly with his soul. Thus, he repays their loans of care and the troublesome travails long past, lent to him in his earliest years, and now being returned to the elders in their old age, when they really need it.”

717d

Athenian: “What is more, throughout his life he should have and retain the utmost respect in addressing his own parents, because there is a heavy penalty to be paid for frivolous,

ill-considered words, for Nemesis has been appointed as the messenger of Justice and overseer of all such matters.⁶¹ So, if his parents get angry he should be submissive, and whether they express the anger in words or in deeds he should be forgiving, as it is only to be expected that a father who thinks he is being treated unjustly by his own son would be especially angry. And when his parents die, the most restrained funeral is the very best, neither exceeding the usual level of pomp, nor falling short of what his forefathers gave to their own ancestors. And, in like manner, every year he should render the services that bestow honour upon those who have already died, and he should show his respect for the departed, especially by preserving their perpetual memory unfailingly and allocating them the appropriate measure of the fund that fortune provides. If each of us were to act in this way, and live by these precepts, we would reap the deserved rewards from the gods and those who are superior to us, and live most of our lives in hope and optimism.”

718a

Athenian: “By fulfilling his duties in relation to offspring, kindred, friends, fellow citizens, and any divinely ordained services to strangers, and through his interaction with all of these, a man should bring order to his own life and brighten it in the process. The system of the laws themselves, by persuading some people, and by just and forceful punishment of those whose characters resist persuasion, renders our city blessed and happy with the counsel of the gods. Now, there are matters that do not lend themselves to being expressed in the form of a law, which a legislator who thinks as I do should and must address. In these cases, I think he should present an example for himself and for the people he is legislating for after he has worked through all the outstanding matters as best he can, and then make a start on enacting laws. In what form then are such matters best laid down? It is not at all easy to

encapsulate these in a single formulation, or outline, as it were. But if we are able to attain any certainty about these matters, it would be in some such manner as follows.”

Clinias: What manner?

Athenian: I would like the citizens to be extremely receptive towards excellence, and this of course is what the lawgiver aims for in all his legislation.

Clinias: Of course.

718d

Athenian: Well, I thought that what has already been said might prove somewhat useful in making the hearer listen to the exhortations in a more gentle and kindly spirit, provided the soul that receives them is not entirely savage. So, if this makes the person who hears it even a little kinder and easier to instruct, that is a most welcome outcome. For it is not very easy to come across people who are eager to become excellent to the greatest possible extent in the shortest possible time; they are not that plentiful. The majority of people make it plain that Hesiod was wise when he said that the path of badness is smooth, and no sweat is involved in taking it as it is very short. But of the path of excellence he says:

*In front of goodness the immortal gods
Have set the sweat of toil, and thereunto
Long is the road and steep, and rough withal
The first ascent; but when the crest is won,
'Tis easy travelling, albeit 'twas hard.*⁶²

Clinias: Yes, I think he expressed that beautifully.

Athenian: Very much so. But I would like to introduce something else for your consideration: the effect the preceding argument had on me personally.

Clinias: Proceed.

719b

Athenian: Let us have a discussion with the lawgiver and say, “Tell us, O lawgiver, if you really did know what we should do and say, isn’t it obvious that you would tell us?”

Clinias: Necessarily.

Athenian: “Well, didn’t we hear you saying a little earlier that a lawgiver should not allow the poets to compose whatever pleases themselves? For they would never know when they are saying something contrary to the laws and doing harm to the city.”

Clinias: True.

Athenian: Suppose then we were to speak on behalf of the poets. Would the following be a fair case to make?

Clinias: What case?

719c

Athenian: As follows. “There is an ancient story, O lawgiver, often repeated by ourselves with the agreement of everyone else, that a poet, when seated upon the tripod of the Muses, is out of his own mind. He is like a fountain, allowing whatever arises to flow forth freely, and since his skill lies in the realm of imitation, he must necessarily, by setting various characters in opposition to one another, often end up speaking in opposition to himself without knowing which of the contradictory positions is true and which is false. But it is not possible for a lawgiver to do this in a law; rather he must always present a single statement on a single matter, and not two statements about one matter. Consider this in the light of what you have just been saying. A funeral may be extravagant, it may be austere, or it may be moderate, but you chose one, the moderate one, and you prescribed this and favoured this one, pure and simple. But in my case, if an exceptionally wealthy

woman in one of my plays were to give directions for her own burial, I would favour the extravagant funeral. But in contrast, a poor and miserly man would favour the shabby version, while a man of moderate means and moderate character would favour that very funeral. But in your case, you shouldn't simply use the word 'moderate' as you did just now. No, you must say what moderation is, and the extent of it, or else accept that such a statement does not yet constitute law."

Clinias: Very true.

720a

Athenian: So, does the person we appoint to preside over the laws add no preamble of this sort to the beginning of the laws? Does he just tell us, straight away, what we should do and what we shouldn't, threaten us with a penalty if we disobey, and then move on to another law, without offering a single word of encouragement or persuasion to those who live under his law code? Just as one physician always treats us in one way while another treats us differently, and we remember both methods, so do we make a request of the lawgiver, just as children make requests of a physician, to treat us by means of the mildest method. Would you like us to give an example? Well, there are physicians and there are physicians' assistants, whom of course we also call physicians.

Clinias: Certainly.

720b

Athenian: Well, they may be slaves or they may be free, but the slaves acquire their expertise under the direction of their masters through observation and experience, and not based on nature, which is how the free physicians have learned the skill themselves and instruct their own pupils. Would you accept that there are these two kinds of what we call physicians?

Clinias: Of course.

720c

Athenian: Now, are you also aware that the sick people in our cities include slaves and free, and that slaves are, for the most part, treated by slaves who either travel about or remain in their clinics? No physician of this sort ever gives any account of the particular diseases of the various household slaves, nor does he ask them for one. Having prescribed what seems best to him based on his experience, as if he knew exactly what to do, like an assertive tyrant he then jumps up and moves on to another sick slave, and in this way he provides some respite to his master in caring for sick people. The free physician, on the other hand, for the most part treats and looks after the diseases of those who are free, and scrutinises these from their inception according to nature. He interacts with the sick person and his loved ones, and he himself learns something from him, and at the same time, insofar as it is possible to do so, he instructs the sick person himself, and he does not prescribe anything until he has somehow won him over. Only then, while continually ensuring the co-operation of the patient through persuasion, does he attempt to complete the task of restoring him to health. Which of these two ways in which a physician cures people, or a trainer trains people, is better – the one that performs the single function in two ways, or the one that does it in one way only, the worst of the two, and annoys the patient in the process?

Clinias: The twofold approach is better by far, stranger.

721a

Athenian: Would you like us then to look at the twofold method and the simple method, operating in legislative activities themselves?

Clinias: I would, indeed.

Athenian: Come on then, by the gods, what is the first law that the lawgiver would enact? Wouldn't he, according to nature,

use legal regulations to set in order, first, the beginning of the generation of cities?

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: Now, isn't conjugal union in marriage the beginning of the generation of all cities?

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: So enacting marriage laws first is likely to be the best way for any city to legislate correctly.

Clinias: Entirely so.

721b

Athenian: Well, let us first state the simple version, it would go somewhat as follows. "A man is to marry between the ages of thirty and thirty-five. If he does not, he is to be penalised by a fine or by loss of status. The fine is to be such and such an amount, and he will lose status in such and such a manner." So, in the case of marriage, let something like that be the simple version of the law and let the twofold version be as follows. "A man is to marry between the ages of thirty and thirty-five, recognising that there is a way in which the human race naturally partakes of immortality, a desire naturally inherent in everyone in various forms. Indeed, a desire to be famous and not lie anonymous in our graves when we die is a desire of this sort. Now, the human kind is, by nature, as old as time itself, its constant companion to the very end. It is immortal in the following way: by leaving its children's children behind, and being always one and the same, it partakes of immortality through the process of procreation. To withhold oneself from this intentionally then is always an unholy act, and whoever totally disregards wife and children is purposely withholding himself. Now, whoever obeys the law avoids any penalty, but the person who turns thirty-five without having married should be penalised an annual amount of such and such in case the

solitary life might seem to be a source of profit and ease. And he is to have no share either in the rewards which the younger people in the city bestow from time to time upon their elders.” Having heard this longer version, along with the other one, it is possible in each case to form a view as to whether our laws should thus be double in length, at the very least, because they persuade and threaten at the same time, or simple and short because they only threaten.

721e

Megillus: The Spartan way, stranger, is always to prefer the shorter alternative. Yet if I were asked to act as a judge of these statutes of yours, and decide which of the two I would prefer to incorporate into my city’s law code, I would choose the longer version. And, indeed, based on this model, given these two alternatives, I would make the very same choice in relation to any law. But let’s not forget that Clinias here should also, I presume, approve of these legal arrangements, since the city that is now thinking of making use of such laws, is his.

Clinias: Well said, Megillus.

722b

Athenian: Now, it is extremely foolish to argue over whether the statutes are to be long or short, since we should value what’s best rather than what is shortest or longest. In the laws just mentioned, one kind is not superior to the other in practical excellence alone. No, as we have just said, the example of the two physicians sets this out in the correct manner. And in this respect, no lawgiver ever seems to have realised that when it comes to legislation, they can make use of two approaches, persuasion and force, depending on the level of education of the broad mass of people. They make use of only one of these, since force is never combined with persuasion when they are enacting laws, they only use unalloyed force. But, good men, I can also see yet a third requirement in relation to laws, and it is

never present nowadays.

Clinias: What requirement?

722c

Athenian: Something that has emerged by some divine guidance from the issues we have now been discussing. Indeed, since we began to speak about the laws, dawn has turned to high noon, we now find ourselves in this glorious resting place, and all the while we have been discussing nothing else but laws. And yet it seems to me that we are only now beginning to speak of laws, while all our previous discussions were but preambles to laws. Why do I say this? I wish to point out that all speeches and other uses of the human voice have their preambles and what you might call ‘preliminaries’, providing an artistic introduction which helps with whatever is going to come next. And so, for instance, we place wonderfully intricate preludes before the so-called ‘nomes’ of a harp song or other musical compositions, but when it comes to actual ‘nomes’, those we refer to as civic laws,⁶³ no one has so much as mentioned a preamble, or fashioned one and presented it for all to see, as if this is unnatural. But our exposition indicates that this is natural, I believe, and the laws I mentioned, that seemed to me to be twofold, are not really twofold in that simple sense. There are in fact two distinct things – the law and the preamble to the law. The tyrannical direction which we said was comparable to the directions of the physicians, who, we said, are not free, is law that is not mixed with anything else. But what’s said prior to this, the persuasive part as Megillus termed it, although it is indeed persuasive, serves the same function as a preamble does in relation to speeches. So it seems quite obvious to me that the entire persuasive discourse is delivered so that the person to whom the lawgiver presents the law will receive it in a spirit of goodwill, and, because of that, will easily understand his direction, which is the law. Therefore, according to my account

of the matter, this should be referred to as a preamble to the law, and not as a statement of the law. Now, having said all this, what would I like to say next? It is as follows. The lawgiver is always to see that the laws as a whole, and each of them individually, are not made without preambles. This will make as big a difference to the laws themselves as it did in the example of the two physicians.

723b

Clinias: Well, I too would have us direct the lawgiver, who is knowledgeable about all this, to legislate in no other way.

723c

Athenian: Yes, Clinias, I think you are putting that very well. There are preambles to all laws, and in setting about the legislative process, it is necessary to prefix to each law the preamble that naturally belongs to the subject matter as a whole since the pronouncement that follows this preamble is not trivial, and it makes a big difference whether it is remembered clearly or not. However, it would be wrong of us to insist that preambles must be provided for laws which are said to be important, and for minor laws too in like manner. Indeed, it is not necessary to do this for every song or speech, and even though there is a natural prelude for each, it need not be used in all cases; such a decision is left to the rhetorician, the musician, or the lawgiver himself, in each case.

723d

Clinias: I think that's very true, but, stranger, let's not delay any longer. Let's return to the argument, beginning, if that's acceptable to you, from those assertions which you made then, though not as a preamble. So yet again, let's repeat this once more from the beginning, this time as a preamble, rather than conducting a random argument as we did just now. "Better second time around", as they say when playing games. Enough has already been said about the honour and service due to gods and ancestors. So we should attempt to recount whatever

comes next in order, until, in your opinion, the entire preamble has been stated adequately. Only then should you proceed to describe the laws themselves.

724a

Athenian: In that case, we are now saying that, in relation to gods, those alongside them and parents who are living or deceased, we provided an adequate preamble at the time. And, as I see it, you are now asking me, in a sense, to shed some light upon whatever has been left out of such considerations.

Clinias: Entirely so.

724b

Athenian: Well then, after such matters as these, isn't it both fitting and of great mutual benefit for the speaker and the listener to attain the best possible education by pondering just how serious or casual they should be about their own souls, their bodies, and their wealth? These are the issues we really need to speak of and hear of next.

Clinias: Correct.

BOOK V

726a

Athenian: Give ear, then, all you who have heard just now about gods and the beloved ancestors. The most divine thing that anyone possesses, after gods, is soul, his closest kindred. All things that ever belong to anyone are of two kinds: the superior and better acting as masters, and the inferior and worse acting as servants, and those that act as master should always be held in higher esteem than those that serve. Accordingly, I say that a person's own soul should be accorded a place of honour second only to the gods and those who follow in their train, and I am right to encourage this. Yet none of us really bestows honour in the correct way, although we think we do. For honour is presumably a divine good, and nothing bad is worthy of honour,

and anyone who believes he is exalting his soul with some words or gifts or indulgences, while making it no better than it was before, thinks he is bestowing honour when he is doing no such thing.

727b

Athenian: Every child, for instance, no sooner comes to manhood than he believes he is capable of understanding everything, so he imagines he is honouring his own soul once he is praising it, and he eagerly grants it licence to do as it pleases. But we are now saying that by acting in this way he is harming his soul rather than honouring it, when, according to us, soul should be second in honour only to the gods. Again, whenever a person presumes that other people, and not himself, are consistently responsible for his own transgressions and his many significant vices, while he always holds himself blameless thinking he is honouring his own soul, he is really doing no such thing. He is, in fact, harming his soul. Similarly, when he indulges in pleasures contrary to the direction and encouragement of the lawgiver, he is not honouring his soul at all but dishonouring it by filling it with woes and regret. And again, in the opposite case, when someone won't make an effort to endure the approved hardships and fears, travails and sufferings, but gives in, his capitulation does not honour his soul. Indeed, all behaviour of this sort brings dishonour.

727d

Athenian: Nor indeed does he honour his soul when he imagines that being alive is good under any circumstances. Rather, he dishonours it, for his soul then forms the view that everything that happens in the other world is evil. And he goes along with this notion instead of resisting it by instruction and refutation because the soul does not really know if, on the contrary, the greatest goods of all for us are to be found in the realm of the gods of that place. And, indeed, whenever someone honours some earthly beauty above excellence, this is the same

as dishonouring the soul completely and utterly, as it is tantamount to declaring falsely that the body is more honourable than the soul. Indeed, nothing earth-born is more honourable than the heavenly, and whoever forms any other opinion about the soul has no idea how wondrous a possession he is despising.

728a

Athenian: Again, when someone loves acquiring wealth by base means, or has no qualms about doing so, he is not honouring his soul with such gifts. Far from it; he sells his soul's treasure and nobility for a little bit of gold. But all the gold on earth, or beneath the earth, is not as valuable as excellence. So, to sum it all up, once the lawgiver has set out in detail what is disgraceful and evil on the one hand, and what is good and noble on the other, whoever is not prepared to refrain from the one by every means at his disposal, and practise the other to the utmost of his ability, does not realise that in doing all this he is heaping vile dishonour and deformity on his most divine possession, his soul.

728b

Athenian: For no one really takes account of the greatest judgement, so called, passed upon evil-doing; to become like unto men who are already evil, and having become like this, to flee from and avoid good men and good words, and pursue the other sort of people, cleave to them and keep their company. But in consorting with such people, he inevitably does what they naturally do, and experiences what such people naturally experience and say among themselves. Now this state of affairs does not constitute justice, since justice and what's just are noble. It is, rather, a punishment, a consequence of wrong-doing, and the person who meets with it and the person who does not, are both wretched; in one case because he is not cured, in the other because he is undone so that many others may be saved. But for us, honour consists, generally speaking, in

following the better and doing our utmost to improve the worse when it can be improved.

728c

Athenian: Now, when it comes to fleeing from evil and following the trail of the utmost excellence, choosing that and then living the rest of one's life in communion with that, a human being has no possession more naturally suited to the purpose than soul. That is why we assigned it second place in terms of honour, while third place, as anyone would recognise, goes to the honour that naturally belongs to the body. Furthermore, it is necessary to consider the various honours, which of them are true and which are spurious. This is the role of the lawgiver.

728d

Athenian: Now, as I see it, he will declare these honours to be as follows and of the following kinds. The body that is worthy of honour is not the one that is beautiful or strong, nor the one possessed of speed or stature, nor indeed the one that is healthy, even though this is what most people think. Nor are bodies of the opposite sort to be honoured either, but those that occupy a middle position are the most sound-minded and safest by far, while the other two make people's souls conceited and arrogant in one case, and submissive and slavish in the other. The same holds for the acquisition of wealth and possessions, and the same ranking in terms of honour applies too. For excess of each of these brings about enmity and faction, in public and in private, while their deficiency, for the most part, leads to slavery. Let no one then covet wealth for his children's sake so that he may leave them as wealthy as he possibly can, since this is good neither for them nor for the city. Indeed, unflattering wealth that still provides for our needs is what's best of all, and most musical, for the young. For it is harmonious and it suits us and ensures a life that is free from pain in every respect.

728e

Athenian: We should bequeath to our children a great sense of reverence, rather than gold. We imagine that we shall bequeath this legacy to the young if we chastise them when they are disrespectful, but the exhortation used nowadays, which declares that the young must be respectful to everyone, won't bring this about. The thoughtful lawgiver would, rather, exhort the older generation to show respect for the young, and to be careful above all else lest any of the young folk ever see an elder, or even hear tell of him, doing or saying anything shameful, because where the old have no shame, the young in that place are also inevitably devoid of reverence. Indeed, the best education of the young, and of ourselves, consists not in admonishment, but in being seen to exemplify in practice throughout one's life, the very directions we use when admonishing others.

729c

Athenian: Someone who honours and respects all his kindred who share the family gods and naturally have the same blood, would, within reason, retain the favour of the birth gods in the procreation of his own children. And, indeed, we would secure the goodwill of friends and companions in daily affairs by regarding their services to us as more significant and important than they themselves regard them, and, conversely, by reckoning our own kindnesses to friends as less significant than our friends and companions themselves regard them. Again, in the case of the city and its citizens, the best person by far is the one who, in preference to a triumph at the Olympic games, or in any other military or more peaceful contests, would prefer to be famous for service to the laws of his own land as someone who, throughout his entire life, rendered them more outstanding service than any other man.

729e

Athenian: Furthermore, when dealing with foreign people, he should bear in mind the special sanctity of contracts. For almost

all offences against strangers, in contrast to those against fellow citizens, rely more upon a god's vengeance, since the stranger, bereft of companions and kindred, is more at the mercy of gods and humans. So, whoever is able to exact vengeance comes to his aid much more eagerly, and the one who is especially able to do so is the daimon or god of strangers, the attendants of Zeus Xenios. Anyone, then, with even a little foresight will go through life to the very end, taking the utmost care to avoid committing any offence against strangers. What's more, the greatest offence against foreigners or fellow countrymen is, in each case, the one that affects supplicants of a god. For the god whom the supplicant called as witness when he entered the agreement becomes the special guardian of this victim, so he would never suffer an offence without vengeance being exacted for the wrongs done to him.

730b

Athenian: We have now reviewed, quite comprehensively, all dealings with one's parents, with oneself, the city, friends and kindred, strangers and fellow countrymen. After this, we need to describe what kind of person one should be to live the most noble of lives. So, we should proceed to speak not of what the law brings about, but of what education achieves through praise and blame in making each person more receptive and well disposed towards the laws we intend to enact. These are our next topics. Now, of all goods, among gods and among humans, truth is the leader, and if anyone is to become blessed and happy, let him share in this from the very beginning so that he may spend as much of his lifetime as possible living as a man of truth. For such a man is faithful, but he who loves intentional falsehood is untrustworthy, and he who loves unintentional falsehood is a fool, and neither of these are enviable. For every untrustworthy or ignorant person is friendless, and as time passes and he is recognised for what he is, in the challenges of old age he isolates himself completely as life's end draws nigh.

And so, it makes no difference whether his companions or children are still alive or not, for he lives almost as if he has none.

730d

Athenian: Someone who does no injustice is worthy of honour, but someone who does not allow the unjust to act unjustly deserves twice as much honour, nay more. For the former is worth as much as one person, while the latter, who discloses the injustice of others to the rulers, is worth as much as many others. But he who also does his best to assist the rulers in chastising the unjust is a great and perfect man in the city, who should be awarded the prize for excellence by popular acclaim. And the very same praise also applies to sound-mindedness and wisdom, and indeed to any other goods which, once acquired, can be held by the person himself and passed on to others too. Whoever passes them on should be honoured to the utmost, while second place should go to someone who wishes to do so but lacks the ability. But anyone who holds back and does not willingly share any of the goods with anyone else in a spirit of friendship is someone who should himself be censured, while showing no less honour for the good he acquired, just because this fellow acquired it.

731a

Athenian: Every one of us should be ambitious for excellence without a hint of jealousy, since a person like this makes a city great by exerting himself personally, while at the same time not impeding others by slandering them. But the jealous type, thinking that he has to get the better of others by slandering them, exerts himself less in pursuit of true excellence, and creates despondency among his rivals by criticising them unjustly. By doing so he makes a weakling of the whole city when it comes to competing for excellence, and, for his part, diminishes its good reputation. Indeed, every man should be spirited, and gentle too, as far as in him lies. For there is no

escaping the dangerous, intractable and, indeed, entirely irremediable injustices of others in any other way than by being triumphant in doing battle and defending oneself against them, and by relentless chastisement. And this is an impossible task for any soul devoid of noble wrath.

731c

Athenian: As for the injustices of those who act unjustly but whose injustices can be remedied, we need to recognise, firstly, that no one who is unjust is deliberately unjust. For no one anywhere would ever deliberately end up possessed of the greatest evils, least of all in his own most honoured possession. And soul, as we have said, is, in truth, everyone's most honoured possession, so no one should ever deliberately take the greatest evil into this most honoured place and live his life possessed of that. Now, the unjust person who is possessed of evils deserves unreserved pity, and in the case of someone possessed of remediable evils, there is scope for pity, gentleness and restraining one's anger, rather than raging bitterly like a shrew. But in the case of an evil and corrupt person who does not respond to any entreaties at all, it is necessary to let the anger loose. And that's why we say that it is appropriate and necessary for the good person to be both spirited and gentle, as the occasion demands.

731d

Athenian: The greatest of all evils, innate in the souls of most human beings, is one that everyone makes an excuse for, in his own case, and makes no effort to avoid. It consists in the assertion that every person is by nature a friend to himself, and that this is the way things should be. But the truth of the matter is that the source of all faults in each person, in every case, lies in this intense self-love. For the lover is blind to the faults of the beloved, so he is a poor judge of what's just and good because he believes he should always honour his own above the truth. But a man who is to be a great man must cherish, not himself or what

belongs to himself, but what's just, either in his own actions, or indeed in the actions of others. From this same fault is born the universal conviction that our own ignorance is wisdom, and so we, who in a sense know nothing, imagine that we know everything. And since we don't rely on others to do whatever we ourselves don't know, we inevitably make mistakes in doing this ourselves. That's why everyone must flee from this intense self-love, and always keep with someone better than himself, without feeling any shame in doing so.

732b

Athenian: But there are lesser precepts than these that are just as useful. They are frequently quoted and should be recited as a reminder to oneself. For there must always be some influx corresponding to any outflow, and memory is an influx of wisdom that had previously left the soul. That is why excessive laughter and tears must be avoided, and everyone should encourage everyone else in this. One should try to show composure by completely concealing all excessive joy and sorrow, whether our own daimon is set fair, or it turns out that we face an uphill struggle in certain situations and the daimons face opposition. So we must have constant hope that the goods bestowed by God will lessen the pains that befall us, and change our present predicament for the better. And in relation to the goods themselves, we must hope that these, and good fortune too, will always be ours, rather than all these pains. Everyone needs to live with these hopes and constant reminders of all such precepts unstintingly, clearly reminding both himself and his fellows, in work and in play.

732d

Athenian: At this stage, as far as divine considerations are concerned, we have dealt quite well with the activities that should be engaged in, and the sort of person each individual should be. We have not dealt with the human considerations so far, but we should do so since we are discussing human beings

rather than gods. Pleasures, pains and desires are most natural to humanity, and every mortal creature really is, in a sense, inevitably dependent and reliant upon such powerful influences. So we should praise the very best life, not only because of its superior outward reputation, but also because, if anyone is prepared to taste it and not take flight from it in his younger years, it also proves itself superior in providing what everyone is seeking, more delight and less pain, all the days of our life. It is easy to show without doubt that this will be the obvious outcome, provided such a life is tasted in the correct manner. But in what does the correctness consist? This is what we must now consider, guided by our argument.

733a

Athenian: We need to decide, by comparing the more pleasant life with the more painful, whether the life conforms to our nature in one case, and goes against our nature in another. We should proceed as follows. We want pleasure, and we do not choose pain, nor do we want it, nor do we want neither in preference to pleasure, but we do want this neutral state, instead of pain. We want less pain along with more pleasure, and we do not want more pain along with less pleasure, and when both are present in equal measure we find it hard to make a decision. And when it comes to desire, all these factors, and their quantity, magnitude, intensity and equality, and all the opposites of these, make a difference, or do not make a difference, to our choice in each case. Now, with all these arranged as they must inevitably be arranged, the life in which there are lots of pleasures and pains, great and intense, and in which the pleasures predominate, is the one that we want, not the one in which the pains predominate. Then again, when there is not much of either, and they are mild and minor but the pains predominate, we do not want that life, but when pleasures predominate, we do. Furthermore, we should think of the life in which pleasures and pains are in balance, just as we did earlier.

We want it insofar as it involves a predominance of what we like, and we do not want it insofar as it involves a predominance of the opposite. We should, then, think of all our lives as bound by nature within these confines, and should think about the kinds of lives we naturally want. And if we assert that we want anything that lies outside of these confines, we are saying so out of ignorance and inexperience of the realities of our lives.

733e

Athenian: So how many lives are there and what are they like? From among these, a man must make his choice between the desirable and undesirable, by reviewing them and turning his decision into a law for himself. And by selecting what he likes, and what is pleasant, what is noblest, what is best at the same time, he should live the most blessed life available to humanity. Now, we should say that the sound-minded life is one, the wise life is another, as is the courageous life and the healthy one. And, as opposites of these four, there are the lives of folly, cowardice, licence and disease. Whoever understands the sound-minded life will count it as gentle in every respect, mild in its pains and pleasures, calm rather than frenzied in its desires and passions. The life of licence, however, he will count as harsh in every respect, intense in its pains and pleasures, impetuous and frantic in its desires, with passions that are mad in the extreme. And he will recognise that in the sound-minded life, the pleasures exceed the pains, whereas in the life of licence, the pains exceed the pleasures in their magnitude, quantity and frequency. And so it follows, naturally and of necessity, that one life proves to be more pleasant, the other more painful, and anyone who wishes to live pleasantly no longer has the option of living a licentious life. Rather, as is obvious by now, if what we are saying is right, any licentious person is necessarily licentious unintentionally. Indeed, it is either through ignorance or lack of self-control, or both, that the broad mass of humanity live lives devoid of

sound-mindedness.

734c

Athenian: And we should think of healthy and diseased lives in the same way; they both involve pleasures and pains, but in health the pleasures exceed the pains, and in disease the pains exceed the pleasures. Now, our intention in choosing between lives is not that pain should be prevalent, the life we have adjudged most pleasant is the one where the very opposite is the case. So we would maintain that both the desires and the pleasures are fewer, smaller and less frequent in the sound-minded life than in the licentious life, in the wise life than the foolish one, in the courageous one than the cowardly. But in each case the former exceed the latter in pleasure, while the opposite applies to pain. So the courageous life wins out over the cowardly, and the wise over the ignorant, and comparing the lives with one another, the sound-minded, the courageous, the wise, and the healthy are more pleasant than the cowardly, the ignorant, the licentious and the diseased. To sum up then, the life of excellence in body or soul is more pleasant than the life of degeneracy, and it is superior, in general, in its extraordinary beauty, rectitude, excellence and reputation, and it makes anyone who possesses this happier in life than his opposite in every respect.

734e

Athenian: Thus far, having presented the prelude to our laws, let us end that discussion here. After the prelude, the ‘melody’⁶⁴ should, I presume, inevitably follow, or, in truth, a sketch of the legal and civic arrangements. Now, to use an analogy, in the case of a web or any woven fabric, the woof and the warp cannot be made from the same thread since the kind of thread used for the warp needs to be superior in terms of excellence. For the warp is tougher and has a certain firmness of character, while the woof is softer and, to an appropriate extent, yielding. On this basis, then, we should make a reasonable distinction

along similar lines, between those who hold positions of authority in our cities and those whose education has been less testing. For there are, you see, two components of a political system – the appointment of individuals to positions of authority, and providing those in authority with laws.

735b

Athenian: But there is something we need to think about before any of these matters. A shepherd, a cowherd, a horse-breeder or the like, taking charge of any herd, will never set about caring for them until he has performed the appropriate purification on each community of animals. Having separated those that are healthy from those that are not, and the noble from the ignoble, he will send the second group off to various other herds and care for the remainder. This is because he realises that such care would be a futile and never-ending exercise in the case of bodies and souls that have been corrupted by nature or poor nurture. He would recognise that the corrupt types will also corrupt those who are healthy and unblemished in body and in behaviour in every herd unless the existing stock is properly purified. Now, in the case of the other animals, this is less important and only merits mention in our argument for the purposes of illustration. But in the case of human beings, it is of the utmost importance for the lawgiver to seek out and proclaim, in each case, what's appropriate in relation to purification and all of his other dealings with them. For instance, in the case of purifications of a city, many means of purification are available, some milder, some more severe, and the lawgiver who is also a tyrant would be able to use the severe purifications, which are also the best. But a lawgiver without tyrannical power, when establishing a new political system or laws, would be content if he could effect even the mildest of purifications. Yet, the best method, like the best medicines, is painful, and it effects punishment by justice combined with vengeance, which is taken to the ultimate point of exile or

death, and usually rids the city of the most serious transgressors who are incurable and do her the greatest harm. The more gentle of the purifications might be described as follows. There are people who, from want of basic sustenance, show themselves ready and willing to follow their leaders in an assault by those who have not on those who have. These are regarded by the lawgiver as a disease sprung up in the city, and he banishes them in as kindly a spirit as possible to a colony in what he euphemistically calls “a removal”. Now, every lawgiver must, somehow or other, do this at the very outset, but for us the present circumstances are even more straightforward, since at the moment we do not have to devise a colony or make a selection for the purposes of purification. In our case, it’s as if waters from various springs and winter torrents are flowing together into a single pool, and we need to concentrate on ensuring that the converging water will be as pure as it can possibly be by drawing it off in some cases, or channelling and diverting it in others.

736b

Athenian: There is, it seems, hard work and risk involved in any civic arrangement, but since our present endeavours are theoretical rather than practical, let’s assume that the selection has been completed and that the purity has been satisfactorily secured. For once we have tested the bad people who are attempting to enter the city and live there as citizens by means of extensive persuasion and sufficient delay, we may then refuse them admission. But we should welcome the good people in the best possible spirit of goodwill and graciousness.

736c

Athenian: Let us not overlook the fact that we ourselves have met with the same good fortune we referred to earlier in the case of the Heraclid colony⁶⁵ – escape from terrible and dangerous strife over land, the cancellation of debts and the distribution of property. When a city, established of old, is

compelled to legislate for such strife, it can neither leave things as they are, nor is it able to effect any change, so the only thing left is something like ‘aspiration’ and gradual cautious change over many years, advancing little by little, as follows. Among the agents of change, there should always be people who have acquired a lot of land, who have many debtors and are willing to be reasonable and share wealth with those debtors who are in distress. So they forgive debts and redistribute land, adhering somehow or other to measure, convinced that poverty consists, not in reduced wealth, but in increased greed. For this conviction is the greatest source of security for a city, and on such a firm foundation it is possible to build whatever political order may be constructed thereafter, appropriate to such an arrangement as this. But when this transition falters, any subsequent political progress, in any city, will be fraught with difficulty.

737a

Athenian: Now, although we say we have escaped this strife, it is only right to explain how we might have extricated ourselves if we had not escaped it. So let us now declare that combining justice with freedom from avarice is the only means of deliverance. There is no other way out, broad or narrow, besides this, and we should let this principle be like a mainstay of our city. Indeed, we should somehow or other ensure that property does not provide grounds for dispute among various parties, otherwise anyone with even a little intelligence will refuse to proceed, unless he has to, with a civic arrangement for citizens among whom there are disputes of ancient date. But God has given us a new city to found, one in which there are, as yet, no mutual enmities. So it would be the height of depravity and human folly if founders in such a situation were, themselves, to cause enmities through their distribution of land and houses.

737c

Athenian: Well then, what would be the correct way to make the distribution? First we must determine what the total size of the population should be. After this, we should come to an agreement on the distribution of the citizens, and the number and size of the subdivisions into which they are to be divided. Land and houses should then be distributed as equally as possible to these subdivisions. An adequate population size could not be correctly decided without referring to the land and to the neighbouring cities. There should be enough land to sustain a particular number of sound-minded people; no more is needed. Their number should be sufficient to be able to defend themselves when they are being wronged by neighbouring peoples, and capable of giving some assistance at least to their own neighbours when they too are being wronged. When we have surveyed their land and its neighbours, we shall define all this in practical terms with supporting arguments, but for now our argument should proceed to complete our legislation as a sketch and an outline.

737e

Athenian: Let us assume, as an appropriate number, that there are 5,040 landholders and defenders of the territory, and let the land with its houses be divided, likewise, into the same number of parts so that the citizen and his allotment are counted together. Let the first division of the entire number be into two parts, then into three. In fact, it is naturally divisible also by four, five, and all successive numbers up to and including ten. This much then must be understood by every man involved in law-making – what number and what kind of number would be most beneficial to all cities. Let's choose the number that possesses the greatest amount of immediately consecutive subdivisions. Now, although number as a whole contains all possible divisions for all purposes, 5,040 can be divided, for military or for peaceful purposes related to any contracts and joint endeavours involving taxation and grants, into fifty-nine

divisions and no more, the first ten being consecutive.⁶⁶

738b

Athenian: Now, all of these numerical relations should be thoroughly understood at leisure by those whom the law directs to do so. They are, indeed, as I have said they are and not otherwise, and a founder of a city should be told these for the following reasons: when constructing a new city from scratch, or reforming an old and thoroughly corrupted one, in relation to its gods and those sacred places which should be founded in the city, and when deciding which of the gods or divinities each should be named after, no one in his right mind shall attempt to alter anything that is based upon guidance from Delphi or Dodona or Ammon,⁶⁷ or certain ancient accounts that convinced some people of apparitions that had taken place, or divine revelations that had been reported. Having been convinced, people established sacrificial practices combined with rites, either from that very locality or imported from Etruria or Cyprus, or somewhere else, and on the basis of such reports they consecrated oracles, statues, altars and shrines, marking off sacred precincts for each of these, none of which should be changed in the slightest by the lawgiver. To each of the places a god or daimon, or even a hero, should be assigned, and in the division of the land, special precincts and everything appropriate should be assigned to them first. As a result, gatherings of the various parts, taking place at regular intervals, would provide an opportunity for people to satisfy all kinds of needs and develop a friendly spirit towards one another, thanks to the sacrifices, and become familiar and get to know one another, and there is no greater good for a city than people knowing one another. For where people are in the dark about one another's characters, and they have no light, no one will ever get the honour he rightly deserves, or the positions of authority, or the justice he is entitled to. So every citizen in every city should strive above all else to ensure that he himself

never proves false to any man, is always simple and true, and never falls foul of deception by anyone else.

739a

Athenian: Now, our next move in the settling of the laws is an unfamiliar one, somewhat akin to a draughts player departing from the sacred line, and it will probably cause surprise at first hearing. Nevertheless, through reflection and experience, it will be evident that a city is likely to be founded in the second best way. Yet someone might, perhaps, refuse to accept this because he is not familiar with a lawgiver who does not have tyrannical power. But the most correct course of action is to describe the best political system, then the second best, and then the third best, and having done so, leave the choice to the person in charge of the settlement. So let's follow this procedure now, and describe the political system that is first in excellence, then second, then third. The choice, for now, should be given to Clinias, and if anyone else ever, at any stage, when faced with a selection between such alternatives, wishes to adopt what he likes from his own native land, he too should be allowed to do so in his own way.

739c

Athenian: The foremost city with the most excellent political system and laws is one where the ancient maxim prevails as widely as possible throughout the entire city, that friends really do have all things in common. So this principle, whether it applies somewhere now or will ever apply in the future, means that women are in common, children are in common, and all possessions are in common too, and what we call 'private' is entirely eradicated by all possible means from every aspect of life. And it has been contrived, as far as possible, that even what is naturally private such as eyes, ears, and hands, seem to see, hear, and act in common. And what's more, everyone expresses their praise and criticism as one, insofar as this is possible, being delighted or pained by the same things. Those laws which

unify the city as much as possible set the standard, and no one will ever suggest an improvement on these by proposing any other standard better or more conducive to excellence. And whether a number of gods, or the sons of gods, manage such a city, they dwell there in this way, living lives of good cheer. Hence, we should not look anywhere else for an ideal political system but should hold to this and do our best to seek out the one that is most like this one. The political system we have just attempted would, if it were ever to come into existence, be closest to immortality, and second in terms of unity. After these two, we shall, God willing, consider the third best. At the moment, the question for us is what is this second best and how would it come to be like this?

740a

Athenian: First then, let them portion out the land and houses, and not work the land in common, since an undertaking of this sort is beyond their present birth, upbringing and education. But let the division be made based on the principle that the person who is allotted a portion should regard this as the common property of the entire city, and since the region is his fatherland, he should care for it more than a mother for her children, as the earth, being a goddess, is the mistress of all mortal creatures. And he should hold the same idea too in relation to the gods and daimons of the locality. And so that this state of affairs may persist for all time, the following precepts should be added. The number of hearths, as we apportioned them at the outset, should always remain at this number and neither increase nor decrease at all. The way to ensure that such an arrangement is fixed, in the case of any city, is as follows: whoever has been allocated the portion is always to leave after him, from among his own children whichever one he most prefers, a single inheritor of this holding, his successor too in attending to the gods of the family and city, be they alive or already deceased by then. As for the other children, when

someone has more than one child, the female children should be given in marriage under a law, yet to be instituted, while the males are to be allocated, as sons, to fellow citizens who have no offspring, preferably on terms of friendship.

740d

Athenian: But there may be cases where friendly arrangements are not available or there are too many children, male or female, or where, on the contrary, there are too few due to infertility. In all these cases, the most important and revered official we have appointed, having considered what should be done about the excesses and deficiencies, shall contrive as best he can some means whereby the 5,040 holdings will always be constant. There are many means of doing so, for there are various ways of curtailing procreation in cases where it is excessive, and on the other hand there are deliberate encouragements to having lots of children through the respect or disrespect shown to young people, and through admonitions and words of warning from their elders. All of these means are capable of producing the outcome we refer to. And, indeed, if in the end we fail completely to maintain the number of holdings at 5,040, because the affectionate disposition of couples towards one another results in excessive growth in the city's population, and we are completely at a loss, an age-old device is at our disposal, one we have often mentioned – sending out colonies, suitably constituted, in a spirit of friendship on both sides. But if, on the contrary, some wave of disease ever deluges us, or we are struck by the ravages of war and fall below our appointed number because of the loss of life, we should never, unless forced to do so, take in citizens who have been poorly educated. And yet, as the saying goes, even God cannot stand against necessity.

741a

Athenian: Let us imagine, then, that our present argument is advising us in the following terms. O most excellent of all men,

never relent in your respect, according to nature, for likeness, equality, sameness, and agreement, based upon number and any power belonging to things noble and good. In particular, now guard first and foremost, the number, as declared, throughout your entire life. Then respect the level and extent of your wealth as allocated to you initially in due measure, and don't dishonour it by its purchase and sale among yourselves, or else you won't have the lot, which is a god, as your ally, nor the lawgiver either. For firstly, in the case of someone who is disobedient, the law now gives a direction by saying, initially, that whoever wants to is to take the lot on the following conditions or not take it all. First, that the land is sacred to all the gods; secondly, that the priests and priestesses shall offer prayers at the first, second and third sacrificial offerings. Whoever buys or sells allotted buildings and land is to suffer the appropriate penalties, which the officials shall inscribe on cypress wood memorials and place in the sacred places as a record for the future. What's more, they will give oversight of these matters to ensure their observance to whichever authority seems most keen-sighted so that any departures from these directions that occur from time to time may not escape their notice, and they may punish whoever disobeys the law and God. Just how good the present injunction actually is for all the cities that obey it, provided the appropriate arrangement has been adopted, "no one bad will ever know", as the proverb says, but only someone who has become experienced and reasonable in his behaviour. In fact, under such an arrangement as this, money-making is largely absent, and consequently no one is either required or allowed to make money from any vulgar commercial activities insofar as any so-called base and reprehensible occupation subverts free character, nor would anyone sink so low as to amass a fortune from such occupations as these.

741e

Athenian: Furthermore, an additional law follows from these directions, stating that no private citizen is allowed to hold any gold or silver, but only coinage for the purposes of the day-to-day exchange, which is more or less unavoidable in the case of craftsmen and anyone at all who needs to pay wages of this sort to wage earners, be they slaves or foreigners. For these purposes, we maintain, they need to have a currency that is valuable among themselves, but which has no value to other peoples. And there is to be a common Greek currency for use on foreign campaigns and expeditions, such as embassies, or any other necessary missions on behalf of the city where there is a need to send someone abroad. For these purposes, it is necessary that the city always holds a common Greek currency. And if it ever proves necessary for someone to go abroad for private reasons, he should travel, having secured the permission of the officials, and if he comes back home with surplus foreign money from that place, let him deposit this in the city coffers and receive the equivalent in local currency in return. And if someone is found to be keeping the funds for himself, they should be confiscated by the state, and anyone who is aware of this and says nothing is to be cursed and reproached, along with the person who brought in the money, and, in addition, incur a fine not less than the amount of foreign currency involved. When marrying or giving in marriage, let no dowry whatsoever be given or received, let there be no depositing of money with someone who is not trusted, and no lending at interest either, as this permits the borrower to repay neither interest nor principal to the lender.

742c

Athenian: Whoever considers these practices in the right way, by referring to their principle and intention, would come to the conclusion that these are the best practices for the city to adopt. We maintain that the intention of the reasonable statesman is not what most people say it is. They would claim

that the intention of the good lawgiver should be that the city he legislates for so benevolently, be as great as it can possibly be, and as wealthy as possible too, possessing silver mines and gold mines, and ruling over as many peoples as possible by land and by sea. And they would add that someone who legislates in the correct manner should intend that the city be as excellent and as happy as possible. Now, some of these objectives are possible, while others are not possible, and whoever is organising things will intend what's possible and will not entertain vain intentions, nor attempt what is impossible. Now, it is well-nigh inevitable that happiness and goodness go together, so he would want this combination. But the combination of extreme wealth with goodness is impossible, based, at any rate, on the popular definition of wealth. And most people say that the wealthy are the rare few who acquire possessions that are worth a lot of money, which are just what a bad person would acquire.

743a

Athenian: But if this is the situation, I would never agree with them that the wealthy person is, in truth, happy unless he is also good, but being exceptionally good and being exceptionally wealthy too is impossible. "Why so?" someone might perhaps ask. Because, we would reply, what's acquired from a combination of just and unjust actions is more than double what's acquired from just actions alone, while the expenditure of someone who is unwilling to spend, either in a good way or in an ignoble way, is less by half than that of good people who are willing to spend on what's good. Therefore, those who acquire twice as much and spend half as much would always be wealthier than those who do the exact opposite. And although the second of these fellows is good, the other is not evil as long as he is frugal, but on occasion he is utterly evil, although as I have just said, he is never good. For whoever acquires in a just way and in an unjust way, and spends neither in a just way nor

in an unjust way, is wealthy as long as he is also frugal, but the utterly evil person, being for the most part beyond redemption, is extremely poor. But someone who spends on what is good, and acquires only from just actions, would never easily become exceptionally wealthy or extremely poor either. And so our argument is correct to say that the very rich are not good, and since they are not good, they are not happy either.

743c

Athenian: Now, the intention of our laws is that the citizens be as happy as possible, and as friendly to one another as possible. But the citizens could never be friends where they take lots of legal actions against one another and injustices proliferate, but only where these are minor and very infrequent. We maintain, then, that there should be neither gold nor silver in the city, nor should there be a lot of money-making from base activities, nor from interest, nor from fattening deformed livestock, but only as much as land cultivation yields or provides, and only so much that people do not get absorbed in money-making and neglect the natural objects of the wealth which are soul and body, and these are of no account, ever, in the absence of physical training and education in general. That is why we have said, not just once, that the pursuit of wealth should occupy last place in the scale of honour. For although every human being has three general concerns, concern with wealth pursued in the right way is third and last in the scale, concern with the body is second, but first in the scale is concern for the soul. And, indeed, if the political system we are now describing were to assign honours according to this scale, it would have enacted its laws in the right way. But if any of the laws enacted afterwards turns out to be granting more honour to health than to sound-mindedness, or more honour to wealth than to health and sound-mindedness, the enactment is patently flawed. So the lawgiver should ask himself on a regular basis, "What is my intention, and am I achieving this or missing the mark?" And in

this way, he would perhaps complete the task of legislation himself and relieve others of that responsibility. There is no other way whatsoever to do so.

744b

Athenian: Let the person who has been assigned a lot hold it then, as we say, under the conditions we have outlined, and it would be good if each person who arrived in our colony also had all their other possessions equal. But since this is impossible, and one person will arrive with more wealth, another with less, it is necessary for various reasons and for the sake of equality of opportunity in our city, that there be unequal property valuations. And so, positions of authority, taxes and grants would reflect the honour that each person deserves not merely on account of his own excellence or that of his ancestors, or his physical prowess and good looks, but also because of how much wealth a person does or does not have. And they obtain honours and positions of authority on as equal a basis as possible by measured inequality, and there would be no quarrelling. For these reasons, we must create four property qualifications on the basis of size, called the first, second, third and fourth, or by some other names, to be used when people remain in the same valuation, or change from being poor to being wealthy, or from being wealthy to being poor, and end up in the valuation appropriate to themselves.

744d

Athenian: The kind of law I would enact as a consequence of these considerations would be this. We say that it is necessary in a city that is to avoid the virulent disease which might more correctly be called division rather than faction, that there be neither grievous poverty nor extreme wealth, both of which give rise to both outcomes. So the lawgiver now needs to declare some limit for each of them. Let the limit of poverty then be the value of the lot. This must remain, and no one in authority or any other citizen who aspires to excellence should

ever ignore any reduction of this, in any case, nor should any other citizen who aspires to excellence. Having put this measure in place, the lawgiver will allow some to acquire twice, three times, or even as much as four times this measure. But if anyone acquires more than this by discovery, as a gift or from commerce, or has come into possession of wealth in excess of the measure by some other good fortune of this sort, he shall keep his good reputation and his innocence if he hands the surplus over to the city and the gods of the city. But if someone disobeys this law, anyone who wishes may disclose the fact in return for half the surplus, while the offender shall pay out of his own resources a fine equal to the surplus, and half shall go to the gods. Everyone's resources, in their entirety apart from the lot, shall be recorded in writing in a register, guarded by officials appointed by law, so that legal disputes relating to any property issues may be straightforward and transparent.

745b

Athenian: After this, the lawgiver must first situate the city, insofar as this is possible, in the middle of the territory, choosing a location possessing all the other advantages that are relevant to the city, which are not difficult to recognise or describe. Next, he should make a division into twelve parts, having first assigned a sacred precinct to Hestia, Zeus and Athena, called the Acropolis, enclosed in a circle, from which he will make the twelve divisions of the city itself and the entire territory. The twelve parts are to be equal, in the sense that the parts consisting of good land are to be small, while those consisting of poor land are to be large. He is to mark off 5,040 lots, each of which is to be divided in two, forming a single lot with two sections, a near one and a far one, the part near the city being paired with one nearest the boundaries, the second closest to the city with the second closest to the boundaries, and so on. And in the twofold divisions, we should arrange the proportion of poor and good soil that we just referred to by

balancing the relative sizes of the distributions. The lawgiver should divide the people too into twelve subdivisions, arranging the distributions so that the rest of the wealth of the twelve parts is as equal as possible, and ensuring that everything is duly recorded. And, indeed, he will then assign twelve divisions to the twelve gods, naming and consecrating each allotted part to the particular god, and calling it a tribe. What's more, the twelve divisions of the city are to be divided in the same way that the rest of the territory was divided, and each citizen is to be allocated two dwellings, one near the centre and one close to the borders. And so the settlement will be completed.

745e

Athenian: But there is something we need to recognise fully. All the arrangements we have outlined are unlikely ever to encounter such favourable conditions that everything falls into place just as described. This would require people who are not resistant to a community of this sort, who will put up with lifelong regulation and control of wealth, the restrictions we have described on producing children, and being deprived of gold and anything else which the lawgiver, on the basis of what has just been said, is obviously going to prohibit. And it would require a central position for the city, with dwellings distributed all over the surrounding countryside, as we said, speaking as though in a dream, shaping some city and its citizens as if they were made of wax. Such reservations are, in a way, not wide of the mark, so the lawgiver should take up the argument again as follows. He will say, "My friends, in these discussions do not presume that I am unaware that there is some truth expressed in what is now being said. Actually, in dealing with any future course of action, I think it best that the person pointing out the ideal approach, the one to be adopted, should never forsake perfect beauty and truth. Anyone who finds it impossible to fulfil some aspect of these ideals should avoid that and abstain from that, and arrange instead to

proceed with whatever aspect is closest and most akin by nature, to that one, and is the most appropriate one to undertake. He should allow the lawgiver to finish outlining the ideal, and when this is done, only then are they to consider together which of his proposals are beneficial and what aspect of his legislation involves difficulties. For even someone who makes a most commonplace object must ensure that it is somehow entirely consistent with itself if he is to deserve any credit.”

746d

Athenian: Now that we have decided upon the twelve-part distribution, we should focus intently upon one particular issue – the obvious way to arrange the twelve parts, each with numerous internal divisions, and those that depend upon them and arise from them, right down to the 5,040 holdings.⁶⁸ From this come the tribes, demes,⁶⁹ villages, and also the battle arrays and marching columns, and even the units of currency, dry measures, wet measures and weights. So the law needs to arrange that all these are duly measured and consistent with one another. There is an additional fear that should also be dismissed. He is not to be afraid of a reputation for petty-mindedness if the law ordains that all the utensils that the citizens possess are to have a standard measure. The lawgiver is to regard it as a general principle that the numerical divisions and variations are useful in all cases, whether they vary among themselves or there are numerical variations in lengths and depths, or indeed, in sounds and movements, whether they are up and down in a straight line or revolutions in a circle. Indeed, the lawgiver, in the light of all this, must direct all the citizens, as best he can, never to depart from this systematic arrangement. For in the realm of economics, or in affairs of state, or in practical matters, no single subject in our education has such great power as the study of numbers. But its greatest benefit is that it awakens the person who is sleepy and

stupid by nature, and makes him easy to teach, retentive and intelligent, and because of this divine science, he makes progress far beyond his natural endowments.

747b

Athenian: All these branches of education then would turn out to be worthwhile and appropriate provided you use further laws and activities to banish slavishness and greed from the souls of those who study them comprehensively and profitably. Otherwise you would unwittingly produce an out-and-out villain rather than a sage. Examples of this are to be seen nowadays in the Egyptians and the Phoenicians and numerous other peoples, due to the enslaving effect of their general activities and their wealth, whether some corrupt lawgiver of theirs may have brought about this state of affairs or some bad luck, or, indeed, some other natural factor like that came their way.

747d

Athenian: In fact, Megillus and Clinias, there is something about location that we should not overlook. When it comes to producing people who are better and people who are worse, some places are superior to others, and we should not enact laws that go against these facts. Some locations bode well or ill due to variations in winds or sunshine, others because of their waters, others because the nutriment that springs from the soil not only provides better or worse food for their bodies, but also has a similar effect on their souls. But most advantageous of all will be the localities where a heavenly breeze blows and there are haunts of daimons who receive anyone who ever settles there in a gracious or ungracious spirit. A lawgiver, possessed of reason, would consider locations like these insofar as this is possible for a human, and would attempt to enact laws applicable to these places. So that's what you should do too, Clinias, since you intend to settle a region. You must first turn your mind to issues of this sort.

Clinias: Yes, Athenian stranger, what you are saying is excellent in every way. I must do as you say.

BOOK VI

751a

Athenian: Well then, after all that has just been said, your next task would presumably be the appointment of the various office holders in the city.

Clinias: It would, indeed.

Athenian: There are two elements involved in the ordering of our political systems. First is the appointment of office holders and their areas of responsibility, and deciding how many there should be and the manner of their appointment. Second, once this has been done, comes the assignment of laws to particular officials, and deciding which laws, how many, and what sort are appropriate to each. But before dealing with the selection, let us pause for a moment and make a pertinent observation about this.

Clinias: What is it?

751b

Athenian: As follows. It is presumably obvious to everyone that although legislation is a major undertaking, if we put unfit officials in charge of good laws in a well-equipped city, not only would no good come of them, and not only would the city turn out to be a total laughing stock, but a good deal of harm and damage might be done to the city by these very laws.

Clinias: Of course.

751c

Athenian: So we should bear this danger in mind, my friend, when dealing with your constitution and your city. You see, then, in the first place that those who are rightly advanced to positions of power should be subjected to an adequate test,

themselves and their family too in each case, from their earliest years until the moment of their selection; and secondly, that the selectors for their part should have been reared in lawful habits and well enough educated to be able to decide in the right way who deserves to be accepted as satisfactory, and who merits rejection as unsatisfactory. But in our particular case, where people have come together for the first time and don't know one another, how would they ever be able to choose their rulers without making mistakes?

Clinias: It would be well-nigh impossible.

751e

Athenian: And, yet, once the contest is underway, as the saying goes, no excuses are accepted. And that's the predicament in which you and I now find ourselves since, as you say, you and your nine colleagues have eagerly promised the Cretan people to found this city, and I for my part have promised to join in with this story we are telling. And so, as I am telling a story, I would be most reluctant to leave it without a head, since it would look decidedly ugly wandering about like that.

Clinias: Excellent, stranger. Well said.

Athenian: Well, yes. But I shall also do my best to deliver on my promise.

Clinias: Absolutely. Let's do as we say too.

Athenian: That is what will happen, God willing, if old age does not get the better of us at this stage.

752b

Clinias: God is likely to be willing.

Athenian: Likely indeed. So let us follow God's lead and take note of something.

Clinias: Of what?

Athenian: The audacious and adventurous spirit in which this city of ours will now be founded.

Clinias: What are you referring to, and why exactly are you saying this?

752c

Athenian: See how glibly and confidently we are legislating for men devoid of experience in the hope that they will eventually accept the laws we have now proposed. But this much at least, Clinias, is obvious to almost everyone, even to those without much wisdom: none of these men is going to accept the laws readily in the beginning. But what if we were somehow to bide our time, until those who had tasted the laws in childhood, who had been reared under them and become sufficiently familiar with them, were to join in the process of selecting officials for the entire city? Well, if we could actually arrange this, and if indeed there were some correct manner or means of doing so, I believe that after such a period of transition, a city that had been through such an education might be well assured of survival.

Clinias: Yes, that sounds reasonable.

752d

Athenian: Well, let us see then if we can provide ourselves with an adequate course towards this objective, as follows. For I maintain, Clinias, that more than any other people in Crete, the Cnossians should not merely show due reverence for the region you are now going to settle, but they should also be particularly careful to appoint the first office holders in the best and safest way possible. Now, although this would not be a major undertaking in other cases, in the case of the guardians of the law it is absolutely essential that we pay the utmost attention to their selection first.

Clinias: What course and what plan shall we devise for this purpose?

752e

Athenian: As follows. I declare, children of Crete, that because of your seniority over the other cities, the Cnossians need to join the new arrivals to this colony in selecting a total of thirty-seven individuals, nineteen from among these people, and the remainder from among the Cnossians themselves. The Cnossians should present these eighteen to this city of yours, including yourself as a citizen of the colony and one of the eighteen persuaded to join or compelled to do so with a measure of force.

Clinias: But tell me, stranger, why do yourself and Megillus have no involvement in our constitution?

753a

Athenian: Athens is a city with grand notions, Clinias, and so too is Sparta, and both cities are a long way off. But this is an appropriate role for you in every respect, and the same applies to your fellow founders. Let us take it for now that what is most appropriate under our present circumstances has been dealt with. But as time passes and the civic arrangement has stabilised, the selection of officials is to proceed somewhat as follows. All who bear arms as foot soldiers or cavalrymen, and all who were involved in the military when they were of age and capable of doing so, are to join in the process of selecting the officials. The selection is to be made in a sanctuary that the city holds in the greatest reverence, and each voter should bring to the altar of the god a small tablet on which he has written the name of his nominee, his father, his tribe, and the deme he inhabits, and he should add his own name too, including the same details. Anyone who wishes is allowed to remove any tablet whose details he objects to and place it on public display for at least thirty days. Those in charge of the process shall

present the three hundred top-ranked tablets for scrutiny by the entire city, and each citizen, in like manner, is to vote once again for whomever he wishes. The top one hundred of them, from this second vote, are to be displayed again for all to see. On the third occasion, anyone who wishes is to vote for any one of the hundred he favours, proceeding through sacrificial victims as he does so. The thirty-seven who receive the most votes should then be subjected to scrutiny and appointed to positions of authority.

753e

Athenian: But in this city of ours, Clinias and Megillus, who will make all these arrangements relating to office holders and their scrutiny? We recognise that some such people are needed in cities that are in the initial stages of their formation, but who would they be when no relevant office holders are available? And yet, somehow or other they are needed, and these should be no ordinary fellows, but the very pinnacle of men. For as the saying goes, “The beginning is half of any task”, and indeed everyone always praises a good beginning. But in my opinion the beginning is more than half the task, and no one has yet lavished sufficient praise on a good beginning.

754a

Clinias: Quite right.

Athenian: Well, now that we have recognised this fact, let us not move on without discussing it to clarify for ourselves how this beginning is to be made. However, I, for my part, do not have much to contribute apart from one comment, which is both essential and expedient to the current issue.

Clinias: Which is?

754b

Athenian: I maintain that this city we are about to settle has, as it were, no father or mother apart from the actual city that is founding it, although I am not unaware of the fact that lots of

colonies have often been, and will be, at variance with their founding cities. Yet, at the moment, our city is still like a helpless child who, even if he is going to fall out with his parents some day, loves them and is loved by them, and is always running back to his relatives, and necessarily finds allies in these alone. This arrangement, I maintain, is already in place between the Cnossians and the new city, thanks to their care, and between the new city and Cnossus. So I repeat what I said just now, for there is no harm in saying something worthwhile twice. The Cnossians must play a role in looking after all these matters by picking at least one hundred of the new arrivals, the eldest and the best they can find, and let there be another hundred from the Cnossians themselves. These people, I say, are to go to the new city and join in the process of ensuring that the various officials are appointed according to law and are subjected to scrutiny once appointed. And when this has been done, the Cnossians should dwell thereafter in Cnossus while this new city tries to sustain itself and thrive. As for those who belong to the thirty-seven, these should have been appointed, now and for all time hereafter, with the following responsibilities. Firstly, they are to be guardians of the law; secondly, of the records wherein each citizen writes down the extent of their own wealth for the city officials, except for four minae in the case of someone with the greatest property valuation, three minae for the second greatest, two minae for the third, and one for the fourth. And if anyone is found to possess anything over and above what was declared in writing, the entire sum is to become public property. What's more, anyone who wishes is allowed to prosecute him on a charge that involves neither credit nor honour, but only disgrace if he is convicted because he despises the laws for the sake of gain. So, anyone who wishes may charge him with base profiteering and prosecute him before the guardians of the law themselves. And if the defendant is found guilty, he may not share in the

common wealth, and whenever some distribution of wealth is made by the city, he is to get no share apart from his original lot. His conviction is to be recorded where, for the rest of his life, anyone at all may read the details.

755a

Athenian: A guardian of the law is to hold office for no more than twenty years, and he should be at least fifty years old when he takes on the role. If he assumes office at the age of sixty, he is to hold office only for ten years. And based upon this principle, once a man is over seventy, he should no longer expect to hold office alongside these officials and occupy such an important position. Let us take it then that these are three responsibilities applicable to the guardians of the law. As the process of legislation proceeds, each new law shall impose further duties upon these people, for which they should be responsible in addition to those we have mentioned.

755b

Athenian: But we should now deal with the selection of the other office holders in due order. In fact, we should select generals next and their various assistants in warfare – those in charge of cavalry or tribes, and commanders of companies of foot soldiers from the tribes to whom the title ‘company commanders’ is particularly appropriate, which is indeed what most people call them. Of these, the guardians of the law are to nominate generals from the citizens of this very city, and everyone who is currently involved in the armed forces, or has been involved when of age, is to make the selection from the nominees. And if anyone thinks someone who has not been nominated is better than one of the nominees, he shall name his candidate and the nominee who is to be replaced, swear an oath to this effect, and nominate the other person instead, whichever of the two is decided upon by a show of hands to be included in the selection. The three who receive the most votes are to be generals, with responsibility for military affairs, once

they have passed the same scrutiny as the guardians of the law. The chosen generals shall nominate twelve company commanders for themselves, one for each tribe, and the counter nomination procedure, the election, and the scrutiny, shall be the same for the company commanders as for the generals. This gathering, prior to the selection of a council and its presiding committee, shall be convened in the interim by the guardians of the law, situated in the most sacred and most spacious location available, with one place for the hoplites, another for the cavalry, and a third for any remaining members of the armed forces. The generals and cavalry commanders are to be elected by everyone present, the company commanders by those who carry a shield, and their tribal commanders are to be chosen by the entire cavalry, while the generals are to appoint, for themselves, the leaders of the light-armed troops, of the archers, and of any other branches of the armed forces. So the outstanding issue is the appointment of cavalry commanders. These are to be nominated by the same people who nominated the generals, and the selection and counter nomination process is to be the same as it was for the generals. The cavalry are to vote for them, in full view of the foot soldiers, and the two who receive most votes are to be leaders of the entire cavalry. The voting may be challenged twice, at most. If anyone issues a third challenge, those responsible for counting the votes in each case should decide the matter by a vote among themselves.

756b

Athenian: The Council is to consist of thirty dozen members, three hundred and sixty being a suitable number for the purposes of various subdivisions. These may be divided into four groups of ninety, ninety council members being elected from each of the four property valuations. First, everyone must vote for members from the highest property valuation, and anyone who does not co-operate is to be fined a specified amount. When these have been voted upon, they are to be duly

ratified. The next day, they should vote for members from the second property valuation, following the same procedure as on the previous day. On the third day, anyone who wishes may vote for members from the third property valuation, but voting is to be compulsory for those who belong to the three highest valuations, but anyone from the fourth and lowest valuation who does not wish to vote shall be exempt from any fine. On the fourth day, everyone is to vote for members from the fourth valuation, the lowest one, but those from the two lowest valuations who do not wish to vote shall be exempt from any fine, while anyone from the first valuation who does not vote is to incur four times the original fine, and anyone from the second valuation three times that fine. On the fifth day, those in charge shall present the ratified names for all the citizens to see, and everyone is to vote once more for these or be fined the original amount, thus selecting one hundred and eighty from each of the property valuations. Half of these shall then be chosen by lot and scrutinised, and these are to be the council members for that year.

757a

Athenian: The selection, conducted in this way, would maintain a mean between a monarchic and democratic constitution, and a constitution should always hold to this mean. For slaves and their masters can never become friends, nor can base folk and excellent folk, even if they are said to be equally deserving of respect. For to the unequals, the various equalities would become inequalities unless they hit upon the measure. Indeed, because of these two inequalities our civic arrangements are filled with faction. For the old saying is true, and it puts it most correctly and elegantly: “Equality gives rise to friendship”. But the saying really confuses us, because it is not very clear which precise equality is capable of bringing this about, for there are two equalities that have the same name but are, in practice, almost opposites in many respects. The other equality – of

measure, weight and number – can be applied through regulation by lot, by any city or legislator when awarding honours, in conducting the various distributions. But the truest and most excellent equality is not at all easy for anyone to see, for it is the judgement of Zeus. And although it imparts very little to humanity, everything it imparts to cities or to individuals produces nothing but good. For it allocates more to the greater and less to the smaller, giving due measure to each according to their own nature. And, indeed, it also dispenses what's appropriate, in proportion, to each, always bestowing greater honours upon those whose excellence is greater, and less upon those in the opposite situation in terms of excellence and education. For this very justice, indeed, always constitutes for us the statesmanship for which we hunger, Clinias, and with this equality in view we should found the city that is now emerging. And if anyone ever founds another city, he should enact the laws aiming at this same objective and not the interests of a few tyrants, or just one, or, indeed, some democratic power group, but what's just always, and this is what has now been described – the natural equality that is consistently given to unequals.

757d

Athenian: Nevertheless, it is inevitable that every city will have to apply these principles in a modified sense if it is going to avoid being embroiled in internal factions somewhere. Fairness and forgiveness, you know, are always a departure from perfection and precision, and a deviation from strict justice. Therefore, because of discontent prevalent among the general population, it is necessary to make further use of the equality of the lot, and then call, in prayer, upon God and good fortune to guide the fall of the lot for them in the direction of the perfectly just outcome. And although it is indeed necessary to make use of both equalities in this way, we should use the other one, the one that relies upon good fortune, as seldom as possible.

758a

Athenian: This is what a city needs to do, my friends, for all these reasons, if it is going to be saved. Since a ship sailing the seas needs to keep constant watch, day and night, so too a city, in like manner, battered by the waves of other cities, and living in peril of being overtaken by conspiracies of all sorts needs a day-long and night-long succession, connecting one official to another as guardians hand over to guardians continuously without interruption. Now, it is never possible for a large number of officials to carry out any of these duties efficiently. Rather, the city needs to allow most of the council members to remain at home most of the time and attend to their own domestic affairs. They should appoint a twelfth part of them to act as guardians for one month, distributing twelve parts over the twelve months of the year. These are to meet readily with anyone who comes from some other place, or even from the city itself, wishing either to make a statement relevant to the city's dealings with other cities, or, on the other hand, to obtain some information. When the city puts questions to other cities, they are to receive the replies. And most importantly, on account of the great variety of innovations that tend to occur in a city on a regular basis, they are to act as guardians so that ideally these never occur, and if they do occur, whatever has happened is remedied and the city is made aware of it as quickly as possible. For all these purposes, this twelfth part must always be the part of the city that presides and is responsible for convening and dissolving any meetings, be they routine or the extraordinary ones that crop up occasionally in the city. So, a twelfth part of the council would be the body that arranges all these matters, being off-duty for the remaining eleven months of the year. But this part of the council must exercise its constant guardianship over the city, in conjunction with the other officials.

758d

Athenian: Now, although this would be a reasonable way of arranging affairs within the city, what oversight and arrangements would apply to all the rest of the territory? Since the entire city and, indeed, the territory as a whole has been divided into twelve parts, shouldn't we appoint superintendents of the city's own roads, houses, public buildings, and harbours, of its market and springs, and, indeed, of its sacred precincts and temples, and everything of that sort?

Clinias: Of course.

758e

Athenian: Let us say then that there should be servants, priests and priestesses for the temples. For the roads and public buildings and their good order, for ensuring humans and other animals do not act improperly both within the city boundary itself and in the suburbs, and so that proper conditions may prevail in the city, three types of officials must be selected: those concerned with the matters we just mentioned, being called city-police; those concerned with the good order of the market, market-police; priests or priestesses of temples, who belong to hereditary priesthoods, are to be left as they are. But if, as is likely with such matters in the case of the initial settlers, there are priests for none or for very few of the temples, then priests and priestesses should be appointed to act as servants of the gods for temples without an established priesthood. Of all these appointments, some should be by election, others by lot, thus mixing the democratic element with its opposite in every territory and city with their mutual friendship as the objective, so that they may be like-minded as much as possible.

759c

Athenian: When it comes to the priesthoods, we should allow God to bring about what is pleasing to Himself by entrusting the matter to the divine chance of the lot. But he to whom the lot falls is to be scrutinised, first for integrity and legitimacy, and

then for descent from houses that are, as much as possible, pure and untainted by slaughter and all such transgressions of divine precepts, in his own life and the lives of his father and mother. The laws concerning all divine matters are to be brought from Delphi, and they should make use of them once they have appointed interpreters of these oracles. Each priesthood is to be for one year and no longer. And whoever is to perform holy rituals adequately, in accord with our sacred laws about divine matters, should be at least sixty years old. And the same regulations should apply to the priestesses.

759d

Athenian: In the case of interpreters there are to be three: the tribes, in three sets of four, are to elect four people each from among themselves, and after testing the three who receive the most votes at each election, they are to send the nine names to Delphi for the oracle to designate one from each group of three. The scrutiny of these three and their age limit is to be the same as for the priests. They are to be interpreters for life, and in the case of a vacancy it is to be filled by the group of four tribes from which the person is missing.

759e

Athenian: There should be treasurers in charge of the sacred funds for each of the temples and the precincts, and their products and rents. Three people are to be chosen from the greatest property valuation for the greatest temples, two for the smaller, and one for the most modest. Let the selection and scrutiny of these be conducted as it was for the generals. So, let these be the regulations relating to sacred affairs.

760a

Athenian: As far as possible, let nothing be left unguarded. The guardianship of the city is to be exercised as follows. It is to be looked after by generals, commanders, cavalry commanders, tribe leaders and presidents, and also by city- and market-police once we have selected and duly appointed them. The rest of the

country, as a whole, is to be guarded as follows. Since the entire territory has been divided as best we could into twelve equal parts, one tribe should be assigned by lot to each part on an annual basis, and the tribe should provide five men to act as rural police and guard leaders. Each one of the five is to be responsible for picking twelve young people from their own tribe who are over twenty-five years of age and under thirty. The twelve parts of the territory should be assigned by lot to these young men, one part to one group, each for one month, so that all may become experienced and knowledgeable of the entire territory. Both the guards and their leaders shall carry out these functions for two years. Under the supervision of the guard leaders, beginning with the part of the territory allocated by lot, they should always take the next portion of land in exchange each month, proceeding in a circle to the right, from west to east. After the first year, so that the guards for the most part do not have experience of the territory only during a single season of the year, but as much as possible, besides the territory, they get to know what happens in each region during each season, the leaders at the time are to lead them once more in the opposite direction, from east to west, constantly changing location until they have completed their second year. In the third year there is to be a fresh selection of rural police and guard leaders, five leaders, each in charge of twelve guards. Whilst on duty in each region, they are to look after it as follows. Firstly, they are to ensure that the territory is as well defended as possible against enemies, by building embankments and digging trenches as needed, using fortifications to defend, as best they can, against anyone who might attempt to despoil the territory or property. For these purposes they may employ the beasts of burden and household servants of each locality, using the animals as instruments and taking charge of the servants, while doing their best not to intrude upon their domestic duties. In short, they are to make everywhere

inaccessible to enemies and as accessible as possible to friends, be they humans, beasts of burden or cattle. They are to attend to the roads to ensure that they are as comfortable as possible, and to the rains sent by Zeus to ensure that they benefit the land rather than doing damage. So, as the waters flow from the high places into the mountain glens and hollows, they should channel the deluge with dams and canals so that the valleys either retain or absorb the rains from Zeus, forming streams and springs for the farms and the localities below, thus providing even the driest regions with an abundance of fresh water. By enhancing and beautifying the clear waters of a spring or a river with various plantations and structures, and by connecting streams through underground channels, they shall ensure abundance and plenty. And if there is a consecrated grove or enclosure in the vicinity, they may beautify it all year round by directing the flow through channels into the very temples of the gods. In all such places, the young are to provide gymnasia for themselves and for their elders, equipped with warm baths and plenty of dry seasoned wood for fuel, for the benefit also of those who are ailing, bodies that are worn out by disease and the toils of farm labour, glad to receive far better treatment than they would from an incompetent physician.

761d

Athenian: These activities, and anything of this sort, would enhance and benefit the various regions, as well as affording a pleasant recreation. The serious aspect of their business would be as follows. Each group of sixty is to guard its own region, not only against enemies but also against those who claim to be friends. And if anyone, slave or free, foreign or fellow citizen, acts unjustly towards someone else, they are to act as judges for whoever claims to have been wronged. In minor cases, the leaders themselves, and in major cases, up to three minae in value, the leaders plus twelve of the guards must judge whatever one person alleges against the other. No judge or ruler

should exercise judgement or authority without being subject to review, except for those who, like kings, pass the final judgement. And, indeed, if these rural police mistreat the people they are looking after in any way, by imposing unfair levies, or attempting to seize or commandeer the property of those who work the land, without consent, or if they accept anything given to them as an inducement or make distributions in an unjust manner, let them bear the censure of the entire city for yielding to such corrupting influences. For any other injustices they may perpetrate against the local people, up to a value of one mina, let them submit voluntarily to trial before the villagers or foreigners. And if they are unwilling to submit on any occasion, convinced that they will escape trial by continually changing their location every month, whether the offence is major or minor, the wronged party is to pursue his case in the public courts, and if he wins he obtains twice the amount from the fugitive defendant who was so unwilling to submit to justice.

762b

Athenian: The leaders and the rural police, during their two years in office, are to have a lifestyle of the following sort. Firstly, in each district there is to be a common mess in which a communal way of living is to be maintained by everyone. If someone is absent from common arrangements, even for a single day, or sleeps elsewhere at night without express orders from the leaders, or a situation where it is absolutely necessary, and the five decide to put him on report and display his name in the marketplace as a deserter from his post, let him incur disgrace for personally betraying the constitution, and let him be punished with blows, fearlessly, by anyone who comes across him and wishes to do so. And if one of the leaders themselves does something like this himself, all of the sixty should attend to the matter, and anyone who is aware of this, or finds out about it and takes no action, is to be held guilty under the very

same laws and be punished even more severely than the younger ones by being stripped of all authority over the young. Let the guardians of the law pay vigilant attention to all these matters to ensure either that lapses do not occur at all, or that they are penalised appropriately when they do.

762e

Athenian: Indeed, everyone should keep in mind that no man alive who has not served could ever deserve to become a master worthy of the name, and we should pride ourselves more on serving well than on ruling well, firstly as a servant of the law, since this is service to the gods, secondly as young folk, constantly serving their elders who have lived honourable lives. As well as this, anyone who has joined the ranks of the rural police must have partaken of the meagre and sparse daily diet for those two years. In fact, once the various twelves have been selected, they should resolve at a meeting with the five leaders, that being just like servants, they will not have other servants or slaves of their own, nor shall they make use of servants from the farmers and villagers of the area for their own personal purposes, but only for public purposes. And, in general, they should decide to live self-sufficiently, serving and being served by themselves, as well as conducting a thorough exploration of the entire territory, winter and summer long, always fully armed for security purposes, and to ensure constant familiarity with each district. For it is surely a study as important as any that everyone should know their own country in detail, and the young should be involved in hunting with hounds, and by other means, for this purpose, as well as for the general pleasure and benefit that everyone derives from this sort of thing. These are the people then, and this is the activity, and whether someone prefers to call them secret operatives or rural police, or anything else, any man who intends to preserve his own city competently should turn his hand to this eagerly, as best he can.

763c

Athenian: The next step for us, in selecting the various officials, would concern the city-police and the market-police. There should be three city-police corresponding to the sixty rural police, dividing the twelve parts of the city into three, imitating their rural counterparts by looking after the roads within the city and the avenues extending into the city from the country, and the public buildings too, to ensure that they are always constructed according to the relevant laws, and, indeed, the water supply that the rural police channel and pass on to them in such good condition. They must ensure that there is enough clean water flowing in the fountains to beautify the city, and to meet its needs. But these people must also have the ability and the leisure to look after public affairs. Therefore every citizen is to nominate anyone he wishes, drawn from the highest property valuation, for the ranks of the city-police. When these have been voted upon, and they have arrived at the six names who received most votes, the responsible officials should select three of these by lot, and once they have been duly scrutinised they are to assume office, subject to the laws prescribed for them.

763e

Athenian: Next, there shall be a selection of five market-police, drawn from the second and first property valuations, the selection process in general being just as it was for the city-police. From the ten who receive most votes, they are to select five by lot, and once these have been scrutinised, they are to declare them duly appointed. Everyone is to vote in every case, and whoever refuses to do so is to be fined fifty drachma if he is reported to the officials, as well as acquiring a bad reputation. Anyone who wishes may attend the assembly or a general meeting, but attendance is to be compulsory for members of the first and second property valuations on penalty of a ten drachma fine for anyone found to have missed such meetings. Attendance is not to be compulsory for members of

the third and fourth valuations, and they shall incur no penalty for non-attendance unless the officials specifically order everyone to meet for some urgent reason. Now, the market-police are to guard the good order of the market place, as directed by the laws, and they are to look after the temples and fountains of the market place too so that no one commits any injustice. They are to punish anyone who acts unjustly, with blows and bonds in the case of a slave or foreigner, and if a local person is disorderly in these respects, they may fine the offender up to one hundred drachma on their own authority, or twice that sum when they pass judgement along with the city-police. Let the same powers to fine and punish also be available to the city-police in their own jurisdiction, fining people up to one mina themselves, and twice that sum when they act in consort with the market-police.

764c

Athenian: After this, it would be appropriate to appoint officials in charge of music and of gymnastics, two kinds in each case, those responsible for education and those responsible for competitions. By education officials, the law means overseers of gymnasia and schools, responsible for their good order and standards of education as well as the attendance and the accommodation of the boys and girls. By competition officials, it means judges of contestants in both athletic and musical contests, and again there are two kinds, those concerned with music, and those concerned with athletic competition. It would be appropriate to have the same judges for competitions involving humans and for those involving horses, but it is appropriate that the judges for those who perform on their own, such as rhapsodes and those who play lyres or flutes or the like, be different from those who judge choral performances. It is first necessary, then, I presume, to select the officials responsible for the playful performance of choruses of men, boys and girls that takes place in dancing, and in our entire

system of music. One official, who should be more than forty years of age, is enough for them. One official, who is more than thirty years of age, is also sufficient for the solo performances, to introduce the contestants and pass adequate judgement upon them. The official responsible for managing the choruses should be selected in the following manner. Those who have a keen interest in such matters are to attend a general meeting or be fined if they do not go. This should be decided by the guardians of the law, but if any others don't wish to attend, there should be no compulsion. The elector must make his nomination from those who have the relevant experience, and in scrutinising the candidate the one sole criterion for acceptance or rejection should be experience or inexperience. And whoever is selected from the ten who received most votes should, once he has been duly scrutinised, take charge of the choruses for a year in accordance with law. In exactly the same way, whoever is chosen from those who have been judged is to preside, for that year, over those who perform music on their own or in groups, once he has submitted to the decision of the judges. After these, judges must be selected for athletic competitions involving horses, and for those involving humans too, from the third and also the second property valuations. Attendance at the election is to be compulsory for the three top valuations, but the lowest valuation should be exempt from any fine. Let three people favoured by the vote of the scrutineers be chosen from the twenty who had previously been selected. If anyone does not pass the scrutiny during any process of selection and appointment for any office whatsoever, others are to be selected instead on the same basis, and they are to be subjected to scrutiny in exactly the same way.

765d

Athenian: In relation to the matters we have spoken of previously, we still have to appoint an official as overseer of the education of boys and girls in its entirety. Let one person be

responsible for them, in accordance with the laws, being at least fifty years of age and the father of legitimate children, ideally of sons and daughters, or, failing that, of one or the other. And let the chosen person himself, and whoever chooses him, regard this office as by far the most important of the very highest positions of authority in the city. Indeed, in the case of anything that grows – plants, tame animals, wild animals or humans – the first shoots of growth, well begun, are the most significant factor in achieving their own natural and appropriate excellence. A human being is, we say, a tame animal. Nevertheless a human who encounters the right education and has a benign nature, tends to become the most divine and gentlest creature of all. But if he is not given an adequate and noble upbringing, he tends to become the wildest creature that walks the earth. That is why the lawgiver must not allow the upbringing of children to become a secondary or incidental matter. And since it is imperative to begin by first selecting, in the right way, the person who is going to be responsible for the children, the lawgiver must do the very best he can to appoint someone who excels in every respect over his fellow citizens, and put him in charge of the children. Accordingly all the officials, except for the council and its committee, are to go to the temple of Apollo, and each must cast his vote in secret for whichever one of the guardians of the law would, in his view, best take charge of educational matters. Whoever gets most votes and has been duly scrutinised by the other officials who elected him, apart from the guardians of the law, is to rule for five years, and in the sixth year there is to be a fresh election to this office by the same procedure.

766c

Athenian: If someone holding public office dies more than thirty days before the end of his term of office, someone else should be appointed by those who are responsible for this, following the same procedure. And if a trustee of orphans dies,

the relatives living in the vicinity, on the father's and mother's side, down to the children of cousins, must appoint another within ten days or be fined one drachma per day each until they appoint a trustee.

766d

Athenian: Of course, any city in which law courts are not properly established would hardly constitute a city at all. And a judge who does not speak to us, and has nothing to add to what the litigants said in the preliminary hearing, as happens in mere arbitrations, would never be good enough as a judge of legal cases. For these reasons, it is not easy for a large number of people to judge a case well, or for a few ordinary folk to do so either. The matter in dispute always needs to be made clear from both sides, and time taken through slow and repeated questioning has the advantage of shedding light upon the dispute. For these reasons, those who are accusing one another should first have recourse to neighbours and friends and those who are most familiar with the events in dispute; and if any party does not obtain an adequate judgement before these people, let him go to another court; and if these two courts are unable to resolve the dispute, a third court shall give a final judgement in the case.

767a

Athenian: Now, in a way, the establishment of the courts is also an election of officials since any official also must be a judge of something or other. And although a judge is not a ruling official, he actually becomes, in a way, a ruling official of some significance on the day on which he decides a case by giving his judgement. Granting, then, that judges are also ruling officials, let's say who the right people for the role would be, what matters they should be judges of, and how many there should be for each particular case. Let the most authoritative court be the one that the parties each proclaim for themselves, making their selections together. Let there be two tribunals for the

other cases, one when a private citizen accuses another citizen of doing him an injustice and brings him to court because he wants the issue to be decided; a second whenever someone believes that the community is being wronged by one of its citizens, and he wishes to come to the aid of his own people. We need to say who the judges are, and what they should be like. Firstly, however, we should have a common court for all private citizens who are in dispute with one another for the third time, set up more or less as follows. When a new year is about to commence in the month after the summer solstice, on the day previous to this, all the officials, whether they hold office for one year or for longer, should come together in a single temple. Having sworn an oath to the god, they are to dedicate, so to speak, one judge from each and every kind of office who has the best reputation in each role, and is likely to decide the various cases of his fellow citizens, best and most piously, for the coming year. Once these have been selected, they must undergo scrutiny by the selectors themselves, and if anyone doesn't pass scrutiny, another is to be selected in the same way to replace him. Those who pass scrutiny are to act as judges for those who are seeking refuge from other courts, and their votes are to be cast openly. It shall be compulsory for council members, and the other officials who elected them, to listen to the legal proceedings and watch what happens, and others may attend too if they wish. If anyone accuses a judge of deliberately deciding a case in an unjust manner, he should go to the guardians of the law and present his charge. A judge who is found guilty of such a crime is to pay double damages to the victim, and if a greater penalty is deemed appropriate, those who are judging the case may impose a further punishment that he must suffer in addition, or some fine payable to the state or to the person who brought the case to court.

768a

Athenian: When it comes to crimes against the state, it is necessary, in the first place, to involve the public in deciding the case since everyone is wronged when the city is wronged, so the people would be justified in feeling aggrieved if they had no involvement in deciding such cases. But while the initial and final proceedings of such cases should be entrusted to the people, the trial itself should go before the three highest officials jointly accepted by the defendant and the prosecutor. And if the two parties are unable to agree on this together for themselves, the council should decide between the two alternatives. In fact everyone should, as far as possible, be involved in deciding private cases too, for anyone who is excluded from involvement in joint decision making feels that he has no involvement at all in his own city. That's why there must indeed be courts based upon tribes, and judges appointed by lot there and then, who are incorruptible in the face of personal pleadings when they pass judgement. But the final judgement is delivered by that court which according to us has been constituted completely free from corruption, insofar as this is humanly possible, for the benefit of those who are unable to obtain a resolution, either before the neighbours, or the tribal courts.

768c

Athenian: Now courts of law we maintain cannot easily be described as ruling officials, yet they cannot be denied such a title either, without some qualification. And although we have given a sort of outline sketch that describes some of the details, it largely omits others. For the best place by far for any detailed regulation and classification of legal cases would be at the end of the legislative process. So, although these details should be asked to wait until the end of our process, the appointments to the other offices have, more or less, been legislated for in full. But it is not possible to arrive confidently at a comprehensive, detailed account of every single aspect of the administration of

the city, and civic affairs in general, before concluding a detailed description from beginning to end, encompassing everything in between. So this stage, where we have completed our description up to the point where the officials are elected, would be a suitable place to conclude the preceding matters and start proposing laws. We need no further hesitation or delays.

768e

Clinias: What you have said so far, stranger, is entirely acceptable to me. And now that you have connected the start of what you are going to say with the conclusion of what has been said already, I am even more pleased than I was before.

769a

Athenian: Well, it seems that our thoughtful old men's amusement has been well played so far.

Clinias: You seem to be pointing out how well executed the work of these men is.

Athenian: Quite likely. But let us see if you agree with me on the following point.

Clinias: What point? What are the issues?

769b

Athenian: You know how the work of painters on any of the figures they paint never seems to come to an end. It seems to go on forever, adding finishing touches that involve 'colouring' or 'decolouring', or whatever the professionals call such processes, and never reaches a point where the painting cannot be made more beautiful or realistic.

Clinias: I understand what you are saying fairly well from hearsay, although I have no direct experience of this sort of skill.

769c

Athenian: Well, that is no harm. But we may still use the example involving this skill, the one that has just occurred to

us, as follows. If anyone ever decided to paint the most beautiful picture imaginable, one that furthermore would never deteriorate but would always improve with the passage of time, you realise, don't you, that since the painter is not immortal, his huge labour will have very short-lived results unless he leaves a successor behind him who can repair anything that happens to the picture because of its age, and is also able in future to improve upon any deficiencies in the work due to the painter's own artistic weaknesses?

Clinias: True.

769d

Athenian: Well then, don't you think that the lawgiver will want some such arrangement? Firstly, he'll want to frame the laws as best he can, with the utmost precision. Secondly, as time passes and his plans are tested in practice, don't you think any legislator who is not a fool will realise that there must necessarily be countless deficiencies in his laws, which some successor will have to put right, so that the civic arrangement and good order of the city he is founding will constantly improve and never deteriorate at all?

Clinias: Of course. Every lawgiver will, presumably, want some such arrangement.

769e

Athenian: Now, what if someone had some means of teaching another person, somehow, by his deeds and his words, to come to some sort of understanding of how laws should be protected and corrected? Wouldn't he persist in explaining this until he succeeded in his objective?

Clinias: Of course.

770a

Athenian: So, isn't that what must be done now by me and by the two of you?

Clinias: What do you mean?

Athenian: Although we are about to make laws, we have selected guardians of those laws who are young in comparison with ourselves, we who are in the evening of life. So, as we say, we should pass laws ourselves, and at the same time attempt as best we can to turn these young people into lawgivers and guardians of the law.

770b

Clinias: Indeed, if we are actually up to the task.

Athenian: Well, we should try with all our hearts.

Clinias: How could we do otherwise?

770c

Athenian: Let us address them as follows, then. Dear friends and preservers of the law, we shall omit a great deal that is relevant to the various topics on which we pass laws, necessarily so. Nevertheless, we shall do our best to include whatever is significant and present the whole system in broad outline. You will have to fill in the details, and you now need to hear what your objective should be in doing so. Megillus, Clinias and myself have stated this objective to one another many times, and we agree that our formulation is sound.

770d

Athenian: But we want you to be of the same mind as ourselves, and to become our pupils too, looking to those very objectives which, according to us three, should be the objectives of the guardians of the law, and the lawgivers too. Our consensus concerned one significant issue, how exactly someone may become a good person, possessed of the excellence of soul that is appropriate to a human being. In the case of any of our fellow citizens, male or female, young or old, this excellence comes from some activity or some habit or acquisition or desire or opinion, or instruction in certain subjects. To attain the

excellence we spoke of, everyone is to exert himself to the utmost throughout his entire life, and none should be found favouring anything else that keeps him from these activities. He should even be prepared to break with his own city or abandon it by going into exile, if revolution proves inevitable, rather than submitting to lesser folk under the yoke of slavery. Everything of this sort must be endured rather than changing to a constitution that, by its very nature, makes people worse. This was our earlier consensus, and you must now look to these two objectives and pronounce your praise and censure of these laws of ours, censuring those that are unable to achieve these objectives, while you embrace and accept those that can do so, live by them in a spirit of friendship, and bid farewell to other activities that lead to other so-called goods.

771a

Athenian: Let us make a start on the laws that follow these, beginning with sacred matters. In fact, we must first take up the number 5,040 again, and how many convenient divisions we found contained both in the number as a whole and the number based on tribes, which we decided was one twelfth of the entire, and naturally exactly twenty times twenty-one. So our entire number has twelve subdivisions, and the tribal number also has twelve, and each portion should be regarded as sacred, a gift of God, corresponding to the months of the year and the revolutions of the universe. That, indeed, is why the innate nature of every city leads it to sanctify these divisions, although some have done their dividing more correctly than others, or have consecrated the division more propitiously. So we may now declare that we are perfectly right in choosing the number 5,040, which contains all divisions from one to twelve with the exception of eleven. And there is a simple solution even to this, for one way to solve the problem is to set two of the households aside, and it would not take a long story to prove the truth of this, if time allowed. For now, let us place our trust in the

principle we have just stated, make this distribution, name each portion after a god or a child of the gods, and assign altars and whatever is appropriate to them, where we should have two gatherings per month for sacrifices, twelve per annum for the tribal division, and twelve for the urban division itself. The first purpose of these shall be to ensure the favour of the gods and of all that belongs to them, and the second, according to us, is to ensure our mutual familiarity and acquaintance with one another, and community spirit in general.

771e

Athenian: In fact, when it comes to marital contracts and connections, it is imperative that any ignorance of the woman's family, the woman herself, and the family she is entering, be eliminated, making every effort as best we can to make no mistakes at all in such matters. So even our games should be arranged to achieve this serious purpose, with dancing for boys and girls, which also allows them to be seen, and see one another, unclothed within reason, on occasions that afford an acceptable pretext, subject to modesty and prudence on the part of each. Those in charge of the choruses should be the supervisors and organisers of all this, and lawgivers too, along with the guardians of the law, in relation to any directions we omitted. And it is inevitable, as we said, in all such matters involving lots of minor details, that the lawgiver will make omissions. So those who have ongoing experience of the laws, year in, year out, should learn by practice to make corrections and changes annually until it seems that a point has been reached where regulations and practices of this sort have been defined adequately.

772b

Athenian: A ten-year cycle of sacrifices and choral performances would be a reasonable and sufficient time period to assign for experience of each and every aspect. While the relevant lawgiver is still alive, they should work in consultation

with him, but once he has died, the officials themselves, each reporting to the guardians of the law, should correct any deficiency in their own area of responsibility until it seems that every detail has been resolved, well and truly. They should then declare the laws unalterable, and thereafter administer these along with the other laws that the original lawgiver prescribed for them at the outset. Nothing relating to these laws should ever be changed deliberately, but if it ever seems necessary to do so, they are to consult all the officials, the general population and the divine oracles for advice, and make the change if all are in agreement. Otherwise, they are not to change them at all and, by law, any dissenting group shall always prevail.

772d

Athenian: Now, when any man, having turned twenty-five years of age, upon due consideration by himself and by others, believes he has found a bride that suits him personally, and is also suitable for companionship and for begetting children, he should marry. Indeed, everyone should do so before they turn thirty-five. But first, he should be told how to find a suitable and fitting bride, for, as Clinias says, every law should be preceded by an introductory preamble of its own.

Clinias: Well remembered, stranger, and you have, in my view, introduced the topic at just the right moment.

772e

Athenian: It is nice of you to say so. Now, to a young man from a good family we should say the following. You should enter into the sort of marriage that meets the approval of sensible folk. These people would advise you neither to shun marriage to a poor family nor chase eagerly after wealthy connections, and, all other considerations being equal, always prefer to enter a union with someone who has fewer resources. For this approach would be beneficial both to the city itself and to the families involved, since balance and proportion are much more

conducive to excellence than unbridled excess. And someone who realises that he himself is too impulsive and hasty in all his actions should look for connections to a well-behaved family, whereas someone with the opposite natural tendencies should pursue connections of the opposite sort. And there should be one rule for all marriages: each person is to seek a marriage that is beneficial to the city, not the one that pleases himself. Everyone is always drawn somehow, by nature, to a person who is most like himself, and so the city as a whole develops an imbalance of wealth and character traits. That's how the consequences we wish to avoid in our own city certainly befall most other cities. Now, to prescribe explicitly by law that the wealthy are not to marry the wealthy, the powerful are not to marry the powerful, that the slower characters have to look for marital unions with the quick-witted, and the quicker with the slower, as well as being ridiculous would anger a lot of people. For it is not easy to appreciate that a city should be blended after the manner of a wine bowl in which the wine, when first poured, seethes madly, but when it is restrained by the good company of another more sober god, it forms a good, duly measured drink. Now, it is virtually impossible for anyone to discern that this is happening in the case of the blending of children, and that is why we should omit such matters from our laws. We should try instead to charm each person into placing more value upon the equipoise of their own children than the marital property equality, which is insatiable, using words of reproach to deter anyone who is intent upon marrying for money, rather than forcing them via a written law.

773e

Athenian: Let these, then, be our exhortations about marriage, and also, indeed, what was said previously, that there is a need to preserve the everlasting nature by constantly leaving children and children's children behind us to serve God in our place. All this, and even more, could be said as an appropriate

prelude concerning marriage and the need to marry. But if someone does not comply willingly, but keeps himself aloof and isolated in the city, and is still unmarried at the age of thirty-five, he is to incur an annual fine of a hundred drachmas if he belongs to the highest property valuation, seventy if he belongs to the second, sixty for the third, and thirty for the fourth. The fine shall be dedicated to Hera. Anyone who does not pay annually is to owe ten times the amount. This should be enforced by the treasurer of the goddess, who is to owe the money himself if he fails to exact it, and everyone is to give an account of this matter at the audits. Let these be the financial penalties upon anyone who is not prepared to marry, and he should also be shown no respect by the young folk, and none of them should heed him at all unless they have to. And if he attempts to punish someone, all are to come to the aid of the victim and defend him, and anyone present who does not assist should be declared by law to be a coward and a bad citizen. We have already dealt with dowries, but let us declare once again that it is not likely that our poorer folk will reach old age without ever receiving a bride or bestowing one because of their poverty, since everyone in this city has everything they need, and so there would be less arrogance on the part of the wives, and less low and slavish servitude among the husbands, because of wealth. Whoever obeys this precept would have one meritorious deed to his credit, while anyone who disregards this by giving or accepting more than fifty drachmas towards the cost of the bride's dress, or one mina, one-and-a-half minae, or even two minae, depending upon their property valuation, is to owe this amount to the state, while the amount given or received is to be dedicated to Hera and Zeus. This should be enforced by the treasurers of these two gods, and as was said in the case of people who don't marry, the treasurers of Hera are to exact the sum in each instance or else pay the fine themselves.

774e

Athenian: The right of valid betrothal belongs first to the bride's father, then to her grandfather and thirdly to her brothers by the same father. If none of these is available, authority belongs next to her mother's family in like manner. And in exceptional situations her closest relatives, acting along with the trustees, shall always have authority.

775a

Athenian: When it comes to the preliminary rites of marriage, or any other ritual that it is appropriate to enact before, during or after the event, the interpreters should be consulted, and everyone should be of the view that all is well if he heeds their advice. As for the festivities, no more than five friends, male and female, should be invited from each side, and the same rule should also apply to relatives and friends from either side. The expenditure should be proportionate to a person's wealth: one mina for the wealthiest, and so on, as their property valuation reduces. Everyone should praise the person who obeys the law, and the guardians of the law are to punish anyone who is disobedient, as a boor devoid of education in the strains of the marital Muse. Drinking to the point of drunkenness is not appropriate anywhere except at the festivals of the god who gave us the gift of wine, nor is it safe, especially for those who take marriage seriously, wherein it is most important for the bride and bridegroom to be sensible as they undergo such a significant change in their lives. This also ensures as much as possible that the offspring are always conceived from sensible parents, since the day or night when conception takes place under God is quite unknown. What is more, the begetting should not take place while the bodies are dissolved in drunkenness. Rather, the new life should be fashioned in quietude, well-formed, stable and peaceful. But when drunk with wine, a person reels about, borne hither and thither, his body and mind out of control. The drunkard is a deranged and

inept sower of seed who, in all likelihood, would produce irregular and faithless offspring, crooked in character and in body. That is why a person, all year round, throughout his entire life, should be careful and refrain from any intentional exposure to disease or actions that involve violence or injustice, especially at the time when children are begotten, for he must necessarily transfer and imprint these onto the souls and bodies of the offspring, and produce utterly inferior children. Most importantly, he should refrain from such activities on that particular day and night, since a beginning, once established, is a goddess among humans and the saviour of all, provided she is accorded the appropriate honour by those concerned.

776a

Athenian: The bridegroom should regard one of the two homes in the allotment as a sort of nest and nursery for his chicks, leave his father and mother, and make there his marriage, a dwelling place, and a source of sustenance for himself and his children. For when some element of longing is present in relationships, it binds the various characters together and unites them, while unmoderated and uninterrupted companionship causes the longing to ebb away with the passage of time because of the over-familiarity. That is why the married couple should leave their own homes to the mother, father and the bride's relatives, and live like newly arrived colonists, visiting and being visited, begetting and rearing their children, passing on the torch of life from one generation to another, always serving the gods in accordance with the laws.

776b

Athenian: Next comes the question of possessions. What sort of possessions would constitute well-proportioned wealth for the person who acquires them? Most of these are easy to rationalise and easy to acquire, but the case of household slaves presents all sorts of difficulties. The reason is that what we say about them is somehow incorrect, but in a sense correct. For the

various pronouncements we make about slaves contradict experience, and then again accord with experience.

776c

Megillus: What do you mean by this? We don't yet understand the point you are making, stranger.

Athenian: That is only to be expected, Megillus. For the helot system of Sparta⁷⁰ is well-nigh the most puzzling and contentious issue in the Greek world, with some maintaining that it is good, others that it is not. This is more controversial than the system of slavery by which the people of Heraclea totally enslaved the Mariandyni,⁷¹ or the situation of the serfs in Thessaly. So, in the light of these examples and others like them, what should we do about ownership of slaves? Now, I made a point during the course of the argument, and you quite reasonably asked me what I meant. The point is as follows. We know, I presume, that everyone would accept the need to acquire slaves who are as friendly and as good as possible. In fact, for some people, slaves have already proven superior to brothers or sons in terms of overall excellence, and have saved their own masters, his possessions and his household. We are aware, aren't we, that people say this sort of thing about slaves?

Megillus: Of course.

776e

Athenian: Haven't we heard the opposite claim too, that the soul of the slave has no health in it, and that no man of sense should ever trust them at all? And the wisest of our poets explicitly proclaimed, speaking of Zeus, "For Zeus of the wide brows takes away one half of the virtue from a man, once the day of slavery closes upon him."⁷² Everyone makes his own decision on this issue. Some, as though they were dealing with wild animals, do not trust the serving class at all, and with goads and whips they make the servants' souls slavish, three times, nay many times over, while others do the exact opposite.

Megillus: Indeed.

777b

Clinias: Well, stranger, in the face of such disagreement, what's to be done about this new territory of ours in relation to the ownership and punishment of slaves?

Athenian: What, indeed, Clinias? It is evident that, since the human being is a difficult creature, and when it comes to the inevitable distinction whereby we differentiate in practice between slave, free man and master, humans seem to have no interest in co-operating in the process. So this form of property presents a difficulty. The extent of its evils is often demonstrated in practice by the frequent and familiar revolts of the enslaved Messenians, and by cities that own lots of slaves who speak the same language, and again by the various criminal exploits of the so-called pirates that occur in Italy. Anyone looking at all this is bound to be at a loss as to what to do about such matters in general. Only two devices are available to us. If the slaves are to be submissive they should not be fellow countrymen, or speak the same language, insofar as this is practicable, and they should be properly cared for, not only for their sake but more so for our own. The proper way to care for such people is to use no violence towards our servants, and as best we can to do less wrong to them than we do to our equals. For someone who naturally and genuinely reveres justice, and really hates injustice, displays his true stature when dealing with people whom he can easily mistreat. The person who remains untainted by unholiness and injustice in his conduct and behaviour towards slaves, would be well able to sow the seed for a harvest of excellence. And the same may rightly be said of a master, a tyrant, or anyone in a position of power, when dealing with someone weaker than himself. Still, slaves should be punished when they deserve it, rather than spoiling them by using a mere reprimand as if they were free men. Any

address to a servant should be more like a direct instruction, and there should be no light-heartedness whatsoever with servants, male or female, whereby so many masters are tempted most unwisely to spoil their slaves, making life difficult for the slaves as subjects, and for themselves as rulers.

778a

Clinias: That's right.

Athenian: Well, now that we have done our best to furnish the citizen with enough servants, suited to the various tasks he needs help with, we should as a next step draw up a plan for our houses.

Clinias: Yes, certainly.

778b

Athenian: Since our city is new and has no pre-existing buildings, it seems it will somehow have to attend to every aspect of its architecture in detail in each case, including its temples and city walls. These considerations, strictly speaking, precede the matter of marriages, Clinias, but for now, since our city exists in words only, it is quite legitimate to proceed in this way at the moment. Later, when our city is actually in existence, we shall at that stage, God willing, make the architectural arrangements precede the marital arrangements, which shall be the final step in the overall process. For the moment though, let's just give a brief outline.

Clinias: Yes, very well.

778c

Athenian: So, the temples should be built all around the market place, and all over the city, in a circle on the highest places for the sake of security and cleanliness. Alongside these there should be buildings for various officials, and law courts in which judgements shall be delivered and received as though on holy ground, partly because the issues are sacred, and partly because

the temples are consecrated to such revered gods. And among these would be law courts in which trials for murder and for crimes that carry the death penalty may properly be held. As far as the walls are concerned, Megillus, I would agree with the Spartan position on this, and allow the walls to lie dormant in the ground and not be erected, for the following reasons. An oft-quoted verse from a poem puts this nicely, when it says that our walls should be made of brass and iron rather than stone.⁷³ More to the point, we ourselves would rightly deserve to be laughed at heartily for sending our young folk out into the countryside every year to dig trenches and ditches and even to construct some buildings to impede the enemy, all to prevent them from invading our country's borders when our city is surrounded by a wall. A wall, in the first place, is not good for the health of our cities and tends to make the inhabitants somewhat soft of soul, encouraging them to take refuge inside their wall rather than repulsing the enemy. Nor do they ensure their own safety by having some citizens on continuous guard duty, day and night. They imagine that they may sleep soundly, fenced in by security systems based upon walls and gates, as though they were born to a life of idleness, ignoring the fact that a life of ease is a reward for hard work, whereas, as I see it, base indolence and laziness tend to produce more troubles. But if it does prove necessary for people to have a wall for some reason, then the construction of the private dwellings should be organised with this in mind from the outset so that the entire city constitutes a single wall, every building being rendered secure by the uniformity and regularity of its orientation toward the streets. And it will be a pleasant sight, indeed, to see the city arranged like a single house, easy to guard and vastly superior to any other arrangement in terms of security. The maintenance of the original buildings would primarily be the responsibility of the inhabitants, but the city wardens would supervise them, and even use compulsion, by fining anyone

who was negligent. And they would also look after all aspects of city sanitation and ensure that no private citizen encroaches upon public property with buildings or excavations. They must also look after rainwater drainage, and any other matters, within the city or without, that would be appropriate for them to manage. On all these matters, the guardians of the law should legislate as soon as they see the need, and on anything else that was omitted from the law code because it was unforeseen. And now that these – and the buildings of the marketplace, the gymnasia and all the schools – are ready for use, and the theatres are ready for the spectators, let us move on to the issues that come next after marriage, as we follow the proper sequence of legislation.

Clinias: By all means.

779d

Athenian: Well, Clinias, let us assume that the wedding ceremony is over. There follows a period of at least a year before any children are born. The lifestyle of a bride and bridegroom, in a city that is to excel over most others, is not the easiest of topics to deal with, but it follows naturally from our earlier discussions. We have faced a few challenges of this sort previously, but this proposal will be harder for most people to accept than any of those others. Nevertheless, Clinias, whatever we believe to be right and true must be spoken, without reservation.

Clinias: Yes, indeed.

780a

Athenian: Suppose someone proposes to promulgate laws for our cities, dealing with the public, communal lives of the citizens, while believing that compulsion in private matters is unnecessary, that everyone should be allowed to spend their day just as they please, and that there is no need to regulate everything by law. Well, he is much mistaken in this belief that

although he leaves private matters unregulated, the citizens will still be prepared to live their public and communal lives in accordance with his laws. Why am I saying all this? We shall maintain that our bridegrooms should frequent the communal meals just as much as they did before they were married. This custom was met with surprise when it was first introduced in your countries, probably dictated by a war or pressure from some other circumstances among a small population facing extreme difficulties. But once you had been forced to avail yourselves of communal meals and had experienced their benefits, you formed the view that this custom was highly advantageous for the security of the city. And that is more or less how the practice of communal meals was established among yourselves.

Clinias: Quite likely.

780c

Athenian: So, I am saying that although this was once seen as a surprising custom, and somewhat daunting to impose on people, no such difficulty would face any lawgiver who wished to legislate for this nowadays. But there is a logical sequel to this, a measure that would also turn out well if it were implemented. But it is not implemented anywhere these days, and this failure effectively makes the lawgiver, as the saying goes, ‘card his wool into the fire’, and perform countless other never-ending tasks of that sort. This measure is not easy to mention, or to implement once it has been mentioned.

Clinias: What is it, stranger, that you are trying to explain, and seem so reluctant to mention?

780d

Athenian: Listen then, so that we do not spend a lot of time on this issue in vain. In a city, whatever occurs in an orderly and lawful manner produces nothing but good, while anything unregulated or ill-regulated, for the most part undoes the work

of something else that is well regulated. The issue we are discussing is a case in point. Among yourselves, Clinias and Megillus, communal meals for men have been well established, to some surprise as I said, born of some divine necessity. But there are no corresponding regulations in place for women, and this is simply not right. The practice of common meals for women has never seen the light of day, and so the female sex, who are in general more susceptible to secrecy and guile, have been abandoned to their own faults by improper indulgence on the part of the lawgiver. Because you neglected women, you lost control of many things that would have gone much better than they do today if only they had come under your laws. For neglecting the good order of women's lives is not just half of the problem, as it might seem. To whatever extent the female nature is inferior in terms of excellence to the male nature, to that extent the effect of its negative influence would be more than double. So it would be better for the overall happiness of the city to revise this custom, and put things right by arranging all the activities of men and women jointly. But nowadays the human race is so far removed from this fortunate situation that it is impossible for a man of sense even to mention this in other regions or cities where the very existence of communal dining as a civic institution is totally unfamiliar. How, then, will anyone, without becoming a laughing stock, set about forcing women to consume their food and drink in full public view? The female sex would be more reluctant to put up with this than with anything else, accustomed as they are to living in seclusion and obscurity. They will offer all sorts of resistance to being led forcibly into the light of day, and will be more than a match for any lawgiver. In other cities, as I was saying, women would not tolerate even the mention of the correct principle without a massive outcry, but in our city they might be tolerant. So, if you want this account dealing with civic affairs in general to achieve its objective, in theory at least, then I am prepared to argue that

this proposal is good and appropriate, if you both agree to listen. Otherwise, let's drop the subject.

781e

Clinias: No, stranger, we are both extremely enthusiastic about hearing you speak.

Athenian: Listen to this then. But don't be surprised if I seem to be starting from a long way back, for we are enjoying our time together, and we are under no pressure to stop our comprehensive examination of every aspect of the laws.

Clinias: Quite right.

782a

Athenian: Well, let's revert once more to our initial statements. Everyone would do well to bear in mind this much at least: either the human race never had any beginning whatsoever and will never have any end at all, but always was and always will be, or else an absolutely vast period of time must have elapsed since the race first began.

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: Well now, can't we also assume that all over the world cities have been founded and have perished, that there have been regimes of all sorts – some orderly, some disorderly – and a huge variety of tastes and fashions in eating and drinking, and all sorts of revolutions of climate too, during which the living organisms probably underwent innumerable transformations?

Clinias: Of course.

782b

Athenian: Yes. And we also believe, I presume, that vines made their appearance at some stage although they didn't exist before then, and the same goes for olives and the various gifts of Demeter and Kore,⁷⁴ and that some Triptolemus was the agent of all this. And we must presume, mustn't we, that at the time

when these fruits of the earth didn't exist, the living organisms took to feeding on one another, just as they do nowadays?

Clinias: Indeed.

782c

Athenian: And even today, in many regions, we see that human sacrifice still persists. And we are also told that in other regions, by contrast, people dared not taste the flesh of oxen, and there were no animal sacrifices but 'pure' sacrifices of cakes and meal soaked in honey and the like. They refrained from the flesh of animals as it was an unholy act to eat it or to pollute the altars of the gods with blood. In those days, a so-called Orphic lifestyle was prevalent among us,⁷⁵ which held to a strictly vegetarian diet, and they refrained completely from eating living creatures.

Clinias: Yes. This is referred to a lot and the reports are quite credible.

782d

Athenian: Now, someone might ask us why we are now saying all this.

Clinias: You're right about that, stranger.

Athenian: So, as best I can, Clinias, I will try to set out the considerations that follow from these.

Clinias: Please proceed.

Athenian: I observe that for human beings everything depends upon three necessary desires, which result in excellence if people are led aright, and its opposite if they are led badly. As soon as they are born, there are the desires for food and drink. Every creature has an innate passion for all this, and it is full of frenzied defiance at the suggestion that anyone should do anything else except gratify their pleasures and desires for everything of this sort, and be quit of all pain. Our third and

greatest need, and our most extreme passion – which emerges later and completely inflames us humans to madness – is the burning, wanton passion for procreation of offspring. These three disorders then must be diverted towards what is best rather than what is said to be most pleasant. We must try to restrain them by the three mighty forces of fear, law and true reason, assisted by the Muses and the gods of competitions to stem their growth and influence.

783b

Athenian: So, after the subject of marriage, let us place the procreation of children, followed by their nurture and education. And perhaps if our discussions proceed in this way, each of our laws will reach a conclusion. And when we come to the communal meals, and view the issues at close quarters, perhaps we may see more clearly whether this sort of communal activity should include women, or be confined only to men. And having arranged the preliminaries to the communal meals, which are still unregulated at present, we shall place these in front of them, and as I said just now we shall look at the communal meals with greater precision and be better able to prescribe suitable and appropriate laws for them.

Clinias: Absolutely correct.

783c

Athenian: Well, let us preserve the memory of what has been said just now, since all of this may prove useful at some stage.

Clinias: What are you telling us to remember?

783d

Athenian: The three factors we defined. I think we spoke first of eating, secondly of drinking, and thirdly of an intense sort of sexual excitement.

Clinias: Yes, stranger, we shall certainly remember what you are telling us to remember.

Athenian: Good. Let's turn our attention to the married couple then, and teach them how, and in what way, they should procreate children, employing legal threats if we fail to persuade them.

Clinias: In what way?

783e

Athenian: The bride and bridegroom should have the intention, as best they can, of presenting the city with the very finest and the very best progeny. Now, whenever any human beings who are partners in any activity apply their intelligence to themselves and to the activity, the outcome is entirely noble and good, but the outcome is the direct opposite if they do not pay attention or are devoid of intelligence. So the bridegroom should apply his intelligence to the bride and to procreation, and the bride should do the same. They should have overseers, women whom we have appointed, their number,⁷⁶ more or less, and the timing of their appointment being determined by the officials as they see fit. They are to gather every day at the temple of Eileithyia⁷⁷ for at least one third of an hour. At the gathering, they should inform one another of any man or woman of reproductive age whom they see preoccupied with anything else besides the injunctions imposed upon them as a consequence of the sacrifices and solemnities of their marriage. Let this period of producing children, and oversight of the young couples, last no more than ten years in cases where offspring are plentiful. But if some couples are still childless after this period of time, they should separate, having taken advice jointly as to what is advantageous for both of them from family members and the female officials. And if some dispute arises over what is appropriate and advantageous for each party, they should choose ten guardians of the law, accept their remit as arbiters, and abide by the instructions they issue. The female supervisors are to put a stop to any errors and folly of

the couples by going into their homes and using admonitions or threats. If they are unsuccessful, they should go to the guardians of the law and report the problem, and the guardians should deal with it. If even the guardians are somehow unsuccessful, they should bring the matter to public attention by publishing a notice, having sworn on oath that they are unable to reform such and such a person. Unless the person who is the subject of the notice turns the tables on his accusers in a court of law, he is to be deprived of his rights as follows. He may not attend weddings or thanksgivings for the birth of children, and, if he shows up, anyone who wishes may, with impunity, punish him with blows. The same regulations shall also apply to a woman. If she has been reported publicly in like manner for disorderly behaviour, and loses her case, she shall be excluded from the processions of women, or from any honours, and from attending weddings or celebrations of the births of children.

784d

Athenian: Once they have produced their children, as ordained by the laws, a man who consorts with another woman or a woman who consorts with another man, while the other party is still of reproductive age, shall incur the same penalties as outlined for those who are still producing children. Once this time has passed, a man or a woman who shows restraint in such matters should be well regarded in every way, while those who do the opposite should be honoured in the opposite way, or rather shown no respect at all. When most people are moderate in their behaviour in such matters, the regulations can be left to lie in silence, but if disorder sets in among the general population, then regulations should be implemented based upon the laws we have just prescribed.

784e

Athenian: For each person, their first year is the start of their entire life, and this should be recorded in their ancestral shrines

as the 'beginning of life' for each boy and girl. A further record should be kept on a whitened wall in each tribe, giving the number associated with particular archons after whom the years are numbered. Nearby, the names of those members of the tribe who are still alive should be written, while the names of the deceased should be erased. For marriage, the age limits shall be sixteen to twenty for a girl, the longest determinate time, and thirty to thirty-five for a boy. For public office the age limit shall be forty for a woman, thirty for a man. For military service the age limits shall be twenty to sixty for a man. A woman, once she has borne her children, may be directed to do what she is able to do and what's appropriate in each case until she turns fifty, doing whatever military duties are deemed useful.

BOOK VII

788a

Athenian: Now that our children, male and female, have been born, it's only right that their nurture and education should be spoken of next. It is impossible to avoid mentioning this topic at all, yet when dealing with education, it would apparently be better to make use of instruction and exhortation rather than legislation. For privately, in domestic situations, a lot happens that is trivial and this goes unnoticed by most people. Because of their individual pains, pleasures and desires, which run counter to the intentions of the lawgiver, a huge variety of inconsistent habits arises all too easily among the citizens. This is bad for the cities because, on the one hand, the triviality and frequency of these transgressions make it inappropriate and unseemly to impose legal penalties, yet, on the other hand, the transgressions subvert the laws that have already been passed by accustoming the people to acting contrary to the laws in lots of trivial situations. Consequently, although we are at a loss as to how to legislate about these matters, we can't remain silent

either. I shall try to clarify what I mean by presenting some examples, since at the moment what I am saying sounds somewhat obscure.

Clinias: Very true.

788c

Athenian: Now I presume it was right to say that a correct upbringing must demonstrate an ability to produce bodies and souls that are as beautiful and excellent as possible in every respect.

Clinias: Indeed.

788d

Athenian: And in the case of children, having very beautiful bodies means, I presume, in the simplest terms, that they should grow as straight as they possibly can from their earliest years.

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: What about this? Aren't we aware that in every living organism the first shoots of growth are the greatest and most extensive. Consequently, many people contend that the height increase in human beings is greater during the first five years than in the following twenty years.

Clinias: True.

789a

Athenian: Now we know, don't we, that without plenty of appropriate exercise, rapid growth causes lots of physical problems?

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: Therefore, most exercise is required at the time when most nutriment is being provided to our bodies.

Clinias: What's this, stranger? Shall we prescribe most exercise for new-born babes and infants?

Athenian: Not just then, but even before then, when they are still being nurtured within their own mothers.

Clinias: What do you mean, my friend? Are you referring to babies in the womb?

789b

Athenian: Yes. It is not surprising that you are unaware of the physical training that is appropriate at that stage of life, but since this is so unusual, I would like to explain it to you.

Clinias: By all means, do so.

789c

Athenian: Well, there is more awareness of this sort of training among my own countrymen because some people there are more involved in sport and games than they should be. In fact, among ourselves, not just children, but even some older men rear wild birds to fight with one another. Now, they are far indeed from believing that the exercises in which they train such creatures by pitting them against one another constitute adequate training. Indeed, besides these exercises, each owner keeps his bird concealed about his person, smaller ones in their hands, and larger ones under their arm. They go about, walking mile after mile, to ensure not just that their own bodies, but the bodies of these creatures too are in good condition. This much should make it obvious to anyone who is observant enough, that all bodies are benefited and invigorated when they are moved by any sort of shaking or motion, whether they are moved of their own volition, or by a swaying vehicle, by a ship at sea, from horse-riding, or by any other means of bodily transport. Because of all these, our bodies assimilate the nourishment of food and drink and can become a source of health, beauty and general robustness for us.

789d

Athenian: Now, in the light of these arguments, how would we say we should proceed? Would you like us to risk ridicule by explicitly implementing laws whereby pregnant women are to take walks, mould the newborn child like wax while it is still supple, and wrap it in swaddling clothes for the first two years of its life? And should we also use legal penalties to compel the nurses always to carry the children, somehow or other, to the fields, the temples, or to their relatives until they are well able to stand upright themselves? And then, should they persist in carrying the new arrivals until they turn three as a precaution in case their legs get deformed when they are young from bearing their full weight? And shall we prescribe that there should be more than one nurse per child and that they should be as strong as possible? And should we specify a penalty for every case of failure to follow these directions? Or is this too extreme? Indeed, it would result in far too much of the outcome I just mentioned.

Clinias: Which was?

790a

Athenian: The enormous ridicule we would attract. And what's more, we would be unlikely to make much impression upon the feminine and servile characters of the nurses.

Clinias: Why, then, did we think it necessary to mention all this?

790b

Athenian: Here's why. The characters of the masters and free men in our cities may perhaps be more receptive to hearing this, and come to the conclusion, rightly, that any notion of a stable body of laws for communal affairs is a vain dream in the absence of correct regulation of private life in our cities. A citizen who recognises this may well adopt the suggestions we have just made as laws, resort to them to manage the city

nicely, and his own household too, and live in happiness.

Clinias: A very likely outcome.

790c

Athenian: So, let us not move on from this sort of legislation until we have also given a detailed account of the various activities concerned with the souls of the young children, just as we went through corresponding accounts related to their bodies when we began.

Clinias: That is the right way to proceed, very much so.

Athenian: Well, let us adopt this as a common principle applicable to both body and soul – that the nursing and motion of the bodies and souls of the very young, particularly of the youngest infants, when maintained as best we can day and night, is beneficial in all cases. Indeed, if it were possible, it would be good for them to spend their lives as if they were constantly sailing the seas. But as matters stand, in the case of our new born infants, we should get as close to this ideal as possible. The following examples provide additional evidence. Nurses of small children adopt this procedure and recognise its usefulness, and so do the women who treat corybantic conditions.⁷⁸ Indeed, that is why mothers who want to lull sleepless children to sleep do not resort to stillness but, on the contrary, to movement, rocking them continually in their arms, using some sort of melody rather than silence, as they literally charm the children. The nurses use the combined motion of dance and music, just like the priestess who charms those who are out of their minds using cures from the Bacchic rites.

Clinias: What, stranger, is the cause of all this?

Athenian: That is not particularly difficult to appreciate.

Clinias: What is it then?

791a

Athenian: Both these responses presumably involve being frightened, and fright originates in some degenerate state of the soul. However, when someone brings external rocking to bear upon such responses as these, the externally applied motion overcomes the internal motion, which is fear and frenzy, and once the external motion prevails, it produces a manifest tranquillity in the soul and a relief from the distressing agitation of the heart that had been present in each case. This results in complete satisfaction, bringing sleep to the sleepless, and sanity in place of their frenzied state of mind to the others who are wide awake, as they are drawn into dancing and music-making, aided by the gods to whom they offer propitious sacrifices. And this account, although brief, is a plausible explanation of these matters.

Clinias: Very much so.

791b

Athenian: Given that these measures have this sort of power, we need to recognise, in the case of these people, that every soul experiencing such frights from its earliest years is more likely to develop the habit of being fearful. And we would all agree, I presume, that this constitutes the practice of cowardice rather than courage.

Clinias: Of course.

791c

Athenian: And we would accept that the opposite course, the pursuit of courage from our very earliest years, consists in being victorious over any frights and fears that assail us.

Clinias: Correct.

Athenian: According to us then, this one factor, the training of very young children through various movements, contributes enormously to developing one part of the soul's excellence.

Clinias: Very much so.

Athenian: And, indeed, absence of discontent would play a significant role in developing a good soul, while discontent would produce a bad soul.

Clinias: Inevitably.

791d

Athenian: Now, in what way may we implant either of these two qualities from the very outset, at will, in the new-born babes? We need to make an effort to state how and to what extent these two qualities are within our control.

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: The view held among ourselves is that a soft life produces in the young people habits of discontent, bad temper, and a strong tendency to get agitated over trifles. Yet, on the other hand, the opposite sort of regime, based on excessive harsh subjugation, renders them unsuited to life in society by turning them into cringing, servile creatures who hate their fellow man.

791e

Clinias: But how should the city as a whole set about the task of rearing children who don't yet understand speech and cannot yet partake of education generally?

792a

Athenian: As follows. It is usual for every creature, human beings included, somehow to utter a loud scream as soon as they are born, and, indeed, human children, in addition to the scream, are more prone to crying than other creatures.

Clinias: Yes, indeed.

Athenian: Now, when the nurses are trying to discover what a child wants, they are guided as to what to give it by these various sounds. When an offering is greeted with silence, she concludes that all is well, but when the child cries out and screams, she knows there is a problem. So you see that the

infants indicate what they love and hate by these cries and screams, a most unfortunate set of signals, and this phase lasts for at least three years, and that is no small part of one's life to spend well or ill.

Clinias: You are right about that.

792b

Athenian: Now, don't you both think that a discontented person, who is not at all gracious, will be morose, and for the most part, more given to moaning than a good person should be?

Clinias: Well, I think so, anyway.

Athenian: Well then, if during those three years we were to try our best, by all possible means, to ensure that our charges experience distress, fear, and any form of pain to the least possible extent, don't you think that the soul of the child we are rearing would then be rendered more cheerful and gracious?

Clinias: Of course, stranger, especially if we provide him with lots of pleasures too.

792c

Athenian: Now, on this point I can no longer go along with Clinias, wonderful and all as he is. In fact, such a practice is, for us, enormously destructive in every respect, since it is introduced, in every case, at the very start of the child's upbringing. Let us see if I have a point here.

Clinias: Explain what you mean, please.

Athenian: I am saying that the issue before us now is far from trivial. You should consider this too, Megillus, and help us arrive at a decision. Now, the position I hold maintains that the right way to live is neither to chase after pleasures, nor again to entirely avoid all pain, but to embrace the mean, which I described just now as gracious, a condition which belongs to

God, as we all rightly declare on the basis of a prophetic utterance. So, I maintain that any of us who are to be like God should pursue this state of the soul, neither giving ourselves over entirely to pleasure because we realise that we cannot avoid pain, nor are we allowed to tolerate the same behaviour in someone else, old or young, male or female, and least of all, if we can help it, in the newly born, for that's the time when character, on the whole, is chiefly determined through habit. But I would still like to insist, at the risk of sounding frivolous, that all women who are with child should be shown special care for the duration of their pregnancy to ensure that the expectant mother does not indulge in frequent, excessive pleasures, or pains either, and cultivates a gracious, kindly and gentle spirit throughout.

792e

Clinias: Stranger, there is no need for you to ask Megillus here which of us has spoken more correctly, since I myself agree with you that everyone should avoid the life of unadulterated pleasure or pain, and always adopt some mean. What you have said is to the point, and so is my response.

793a

Athenian: And correct too, Clinias, very much so. So the three of us should apply our minds to the following issue.

Clinias: Which is?

Athenian: That all the precepts we are now recounting are what most people call 'unwritten regulations', and everything of this sort, taken together, is exactly the same as what they refer to as the 'ancestral laws'. And what is more, the argument that occurred to us just now, that these precepts should neither be designated as law nor left unspoken, was quite right. For in all political systems these act as bonds between all their enactments, those that have already been written down and are in place, and those that will be enacted in future. They really do

constitute a body of ancestral regulations, truly ancient, which, rightly enacted and practised, shelter the existing laws in total safety. But if they stray outside of the bonds of what's right into disorder, and the ancient supports collapse, it's as if the supports installed by carpenters in a building were to give way, causing everything to tumble into everything else, one thing lying on top of another, both the supports and the rightly constructed later superstructure. With these principles in mind, then, Clinias, we should bind this city of yours together, totally, while it is still new, doing our best to omit nothing large or small, be they laws, customs, practices or whatever they are called. For a city is bound together by everything of this sort, and neither of these is stable without the other. Accordingly, we should not be surprised if the inclusion of lots of seemingly trivial regulations and customs makes our laws quite lengthy.

Clinias: Well, you are right to point this out, and we shall bear this in mind.

793e

Athenian: So, if we could implement these measures precisely until a boy or girl reaches the age of three, and not treat what has been said casually, these would be of no small advantage to our young charges. But the souls of three-year-olds, and four-, five- and even six-year-olds, would need games, and the gentleness should then give way to punishments which are not demeaning or violent, neither provoking anger in the chastised child, nor spoiling him through lack of correction. In other words, we should apply the same principles to the free born as we prescribed earlier for slaves.

794a

Athenian: Now, there are certain games that come naturally to children at that age, and they readily work these out for themselves when they get together. So at that stage, the three- to six-year-olds should gather at the village temples so that all

the children of each village come together in the same place. What's more, the nurses are to be responsible for the orderly conduct or misbehaviour of the children, and one woman in each case, one of the twelve who have already been mentioned, is to be put in charge of the nurses themselves, and of each group as a whole, for one year. These are to be appointed by the guardians of the law, while the women who are responsible for overseeing marriages should select the twelve, one from each tribe, the same age as themselves. Once appointed, she should pay an official visit to the temple each day, assisted by some of the city servants, punishing any wrongdoer, slave or foreigner, whether male or female. In the case of a citizen, where there is a dispute over the punishment, she should refer the matter to the city wardens, but where there is no dispute, she herself should punish even a citizen.

794c

Athenian: After the age of six, the sexes should then be separated, boys being made to associate with boys, girls with girls. Each needs to turn their attention to various courses of instruction, the boys going to teachers of horsemanship, archery and the use of javelins and slings. The girls too may take instruction in these, if they wish, especially in the use of weapons. For the prevailing view on such matters is, for the most part, misguided.

Clinias: What view?

794d

Athenian: The view that when it comes to using our hands for various activities, the right and the left are different by nature, whereas in tasks involving our feet and lower limbs, no such difference is apparent. But due to ignorance on the part of nurses and mothers, each of us has turned out more or less disadvantaged when it comes to manual activities. For although the limbs are more or less equally balanced on each side, we

ourselves have made them different through habitual incorrect use. Now, in activities of no great importance this doesn't really matter. For instance, it matters little if someone holds the lyre in his left hand and the plectrum in his right, but it borders upon stupidity to use these examples as our models in other situations where there is no need to adopt such a practice. The Scythian practice of using the right hand and the left hand interchangeably to draw the bow and to string the arrow, rather than using just one hand for each, illustrates the point. And there are lots of similar examples, from chariot-driving and so on, which are enough to show us that those who train the left side to be weaker than the right are training them contrary to nature. Now, as we said, this makes little difference with plectrums made of bone, and other such implements, but it matters a great deal when iron weapons such as bows and arrows, javelins and the like are to be used in war, and it matters enormously in the clash of weapons with weapons where there is a huge difference between someone who has learned the skill and someone who has not, someone who has been trained and someone who has not. For instance, a perfectly trained pancratiast or boxer or wrestler is well able to fight to his left, and he is not handicapped, dragging himself about in disarray whenever an opponent puts him under pressure by switching sides. So too, in my view, in the case of weapons or anything else, it is only right to accept that someone possessed of two sets of limbs with which to defend himself or attack others should do his best to avoid leaving either side to lie idle and untaught. Indeed, someone endowed with the physique of a Geryon or a Briareus⁷⁹ ought to be able to throw one hundred darts with all of those one hundred hands of his. All this should be looked after by those who are in charge, male and female, the women acting as supervisors of the games and general upbringing, the men of the courses of instruction, to ensure that all boys and girls turn out sure-footed and good

with their hands, with none of their natural endowments marred by acquired habits, insofar as this is possible.

795d

Athenian: The courses of instruction would fall, more or less, under two headings – physical training relating to the body, and music for the sake of a good soul. Physical training, in turn, has two aspects – dancing and wrestling. In one form of dancing the eloquence of the Muse is imitated, preserving both dignity and freedom. Another form aims at fitness, lightness and beauty, ensuring the appropriate flexibility and reach of the limbs and other parts of the body itself, and at bestowing upon each of them a beautiful rhythmic motion of their own, which pervades and consistently accompanies all kinds of dancing. As far as wrestling is concerned, the techniques invented by Antaeus and Cercyon for the sake of useless ambition, or those developed by Epeius or Amycus for boxing, being of no use in the conduct of warfare, don't deserve to be dignified with a mention.⁸⁰ But the techniques of stand-up wrestling, to free one's neck, arms or ribs, practised with ardour and a good physique, for the sake of health and strength, these are useful for all purposes and should not be neglected. So when we come to the appropriate point in our laws, we should direct the teachers to impart all knowledge of this sort generously, and the pupils to receive it graciously. Nor, again, should we neglect in the choral performances any imitative actions that are appropriate to the particular place, the armed games of the curetes on this island⁸¹ and of the Dioscuri in Sparta. And, indeed, among my own people, our Virgin Queen,⁸² delighting in the entertainment of the dance, thought it wrong to play the game with empty hands, and right to perform the dance adorned in full battle array. So it would be most fitting then for our boys, and girls too, to copy these out of respect for the grace of the goddess, for their military benefit and for the sake of the festivals. So, from the outset, until they are of age for military service, the children should, I suggest,

when in processions to any gods and when involved in parades, always be equipped with horses and armour as they pay their respects to the gods and their offspring with marches or dances, quick or slow. And their sole purposes in competitions, or preparing for competitions, should be these and these alone. For competitions in peace or war are beneficial to a state and to private households, while other exertions, sports or business related to the body are not worthy of a free people. Now Megillus and Clinias, I have more or less described in detail the gymnastics that I said in our initial discussions needed to be described. There it is in its entirety. If you have anything better to offer, please share it with us.

Clinias: Stranger, if we reject this account it won't be easy to come up with anything better to say about gymnastics or competition either.

Athenian: We thought earlier that we had dealt comprehensively with the related matter of the gifts of the Muses and of Apollo, and that the only topic remaining was gymnastics. But what still needs to be said to everyone, and that it should be said at the very outset, is now obvious. So let's state this, systematically.

Clinias: Certainly. That's what we should do.

797a

Athenian: Listen to me, then. You have done so already, but the speaker, and the listeners too, need to be extremely careful when the proposition is highly unusual and unfamiliar, as is the case now. I shall advance my argument with some trepidation; nevertheless, I shall summon up my courage and not be put off.

Clinias: What is your argument, stranger?

797b

Athenian: I maintain that in all cities there is total ignorance about games in general, and how extremely influential they are

in relation to the enactment of laws, and in determining whether or not laws endure once they have been enacted. For when there is regulation ensuring that the same children always play the same games, under the same conditions, in the same way, and enjoy the same playthings, this provision also allows the existing regulations on more serious matters to be free from disturbance. However, when there are variations and innovations in games, and changes are constantly being introduced, and the children's tastes are never the same for long, when they never settle upon a standard of what's seemingly or unseemly in the deportment of their own bodies, or in anything they make use of, they then develop undue respect for anyone who constantly innovates by introducing something new and different from what they are accustomed to, in terms of shape, colour and everything of that sort, and I think we may safely say that no greater harm could befall a city than such a person as this. For he is surreptitiously changing the habits of the young, making them despise what is old, and honour whatever is new. So, I say again that nothing does more damage to any city than the expression of such a doctrine as this. Listen, and I will tell you just how bad it is.

797d

Clinias: Are you referring to criticism of the ancient traditions of our cities?

Athenian: Very much so.

Clinias: You won't find this particular argument falling on deaf ears with us. We'll do our best to give you a good hearing.

Athenian: So I expect.

Clinias: Please proceed.

797e

Athenian: Come on then, let us surpass ourselves both as listeners and as speakers. The fact is that all change, except

when it deals with evils, will be found to be extremely precarious, whether it affects the seasons, the winds, our bodily regimen, or the tendencies of our souls. And this is not, as we might say, sometimes so and sometimes not so, but always so, except, as I said just now, in the case of evils. Look at our bodies, for instance. We see that they become accustomed to all sorts of food, drink and exercises, even though they were disturbed by these at first. Then, over time, from these very materials they grow flesh that is akin to these, and having developed a fondness, familiarity and understanding of this entire regimen in terms of pleasure and health, they live an excellent life. But if someone is ever compelled to change once more to some other worthy regimen, the person is disturbed in the beginning by various diseases, and only gradually recovers as he gets accustomed again to the diet. Now, we should presume that the same thing also applies to people's minds, and at the same time to the natures of their souls too. For when the laws they have been reared under are, through some divine good fortune, stable over a long period of time, so that no one remembers or has even heard of them being different from the way they are at the moment, all the soul reveres them and is afraid to alter anything that has been in place for so long. So the lawgiver should discover, somehow or other, the means whereby his city will secure this advantage. My suggestion is as follows. All lawgivers are of the view that changes in children's games, as we said before, are in themselves a mere game, and that no great or serious harm comes from them. Consequently, instead of trying to avert them, they go along with them compliantly, and it never occurs to them that children who engage in innovation in their games necessarily become very different people than the previous generation of children. Once they become different they seek a different life, and in their search they develop a desire for different pursuits and laws, and none of them fears the arrival of what we have just called the greatest

evil afflicting our cities. Other changes, affecting mere externals, would be less productive of evils, but frequent changes in what is praised or censured in the characters of people, are, I believe, the most influential of all, and should be treated with the utmost caution.

Clinias: Of course.

798d

Athenian: Well now, do we still believe the previous arguments in which we asserted that rhythms, and music in general, are imitations of the manners of better people or worse people? Or where do we stand?

Clinias: Our opinion on the matter would remain unchanged.

Athenian: Should we maintain then that every possible means must be devised to ensure that our children neither develop the desire to come up with alternative imitations, in dance or in song, nor that anyone lures them in that direction with pleasures of all sorts?

Clinias: Correct.

798e

Athenian: For such purposes, can any of us suggest any device better than what the Egyptians use?

Clinias: What are you referring to?

799a

Athenian: Making all dance and all song sacred, having first regulated the festivals by drawing up an annual list prescribing which festivals are to be celebrated, at what times, dedicated to what particular gods, children of gods or daimons. After this, certain people must first ordain which hymn is to be sung at the various sacrifices to the gods, and with which dances the sacrifice is to be graced on that occasion. Once these have been ordained, all the citizens, communally, having performed sacrifices to the Fates and to all the other gods, should

consecrate the relevant hymns to the particular gods and divinities. But if anyone introduces other hymns or dances besides these to any god, the priests and priestesses, assisted by the guardians of the law, shall be performing a sacred and lawful act in excluding the offender from the festival. And if he is unwilling to accept his exclusion, he shall, for the rest of his life, be subject to a charge of impiety by anyone who wishes to pursue the matter.

Clinias: And rightly so.

799c

Athenian: Well, having embarked upon this argument, we should behave in a manner that becomes us.

Clinias: What are you referring to?

799d

Athenian: No young person, presumably, not to mention the elderly, on seeing or hearing anything strange and not at all familiar, would ever, I imagine, rush to some hasty resolution of the difficulties on the spot. He would pause, like someone who had arrived at a crossroads as he travelled alone or with others and did not really know the right road to take. He would question himself and others in the light of the difficulty and would not proceed further until he had settled the question of where precisely the road would lead him. And that is exactly what we should do now. For having just come across a strange argument in relation to laws, we need to investigate it thoroughly, I presume, and not, at our age, make pronouncements so glibly on such important matters, insisting there and then that we have something illuminating to impart.

Clinias: Very true.

799e

Athenian: Now, although we should allow time for this and only settle the issue after a comprehensive investigation, we do

not wish to be prevented needlessly from completing the subsequent arrangement of the laws that are now before us, so we should go on to the end of them. For perhaps, God willing, once this exposition as a whole reaches a conclusion, it may also proffer an adequate solution to our present difficulty.

Clinias: That's an excellent suggestion, stranger, let's do as you say.

800a

Athenian: So let's accept this unusual doctrine. We say that our hymns have become 'measures',⁸³ and that is just what the men of old seem to have called their harp-tunes too, so perhaps these people would not distance themselves entirely from what we are now saying, and one of them, I suspect, had an inspired vision of this whilst asleep, or in a waking dream. So let the following pronouncement be made on this matter. No one, in action or utterance, is to depart from the publicly prescribed tunes, rituals or choral performances of the young, any more than he would depart from any of the other legal measures. Whoever conforms shall suffer no penalty, but whoever disobeys, as we said just now, shall be punished by the guardians of the law, the priestesses and the priests. May we now take it that these issues have been settled by our argument?

Clinias: We may.

800b

Athenian: In what way, then, could someone legislate on these matters without becoming a total laughing stock? Let us look at this further issue concerning them. The safest approach is to contrive some aspects theoretically first. So I suggest the following. Suppose a sacrifice has been conducted and the offerings have been burned in accordance with the law, and some individual, a son or a brother, standing close to the altar and the offerings, were to utter all sorts of outright

blasphemies; wouldn't we expect this outburst to fill his father and other relations with despair, foreboding, and ominous apprehensions?

Clinias: Indeed.

800d

Athenian: Well, in our part of the world this is more or less what happens in almost all the cities. Whenever some official conducts a sacrifice in public, along comes not a single chorus, but a host of them, who stand not at a distance from the altars but sometimes right beside them, pouring out utter blasphemy over the sacred offerings, afflicting the souls of the gathering with their words, rhythms and mournful harmonies, and whoever provokes most tears from the sacrificing city carries off the victory prize there and then. Now, we shall cast our vote against such a practice, shan't we? And if our citizens ever actually need to give ear to such doleful strains on certain days that are not holy or noteworthy, wouldn't it be better that the choruses be hired in from outside for the occasion, just like the paid performers with their doleful Carian music who escort the dead at funerals? Some such arrangement would presumably be suitable for songs of this sort, and the costumes appropriate for performing these funereal dirges would not consist of garlands and gold embroidery, but to get the topic over with as quickly as I can, the direct opposite. I would just like us to ask ourselves this particular question once again. Are we satisfied that the first aspect of hymns, for us, would be this one?

Clinias: Which?

801a

Athenian: Reverent delivery. And, indeed, our hymns in general must be entirely reverent in every respect or is there no need to repeat the question? May I simply impose this regulation.

Clinias: Yes, impose it by all means. Indeed, this measure would win the vote unanimously.

801b

Athenian: Well, after reverent delivery, what would the second law belonging to music be? Is it that there should always be prayers to the gods to whom the sacrifice is being offered?

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: Our third law, I believe, is that the poets, recognising that prayers are requests made of the gods, are to be extremely careful in case they ever unwittingly ask for bad as though it were good. In fact, making a prayer of this sort would in my view be an absurd state of affairs.

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: Now, weren't we persuaded by our argument a moment ago that wealth in the form of silver or gold should neither settle nor find a home in our city?

Clinias: We certainly were.

801c

Athenian: So can we say what precise aspect has been highlighted by this argument? Is it that poets in general are not really up to the task of recognising, unequivocally, what is good and what is not? Of course, when a poet falls into this error of praying in the wrong way, either in his words or in the melody, he will make our citizens utter prayers in matters of the utmost importance, contrary to our directions. And, indeed, as we said, it would be hard to find an error more serious than this. So shall we institute this as one of our legal models relating to music?

Clinias: What are you instituting? Explain this more clearly please.

801d

Athenian: The poet is to compose nothing contrary to what the city holds to be lawful and just, noble and good. He is not allowed to display his compositions before any private citizens until they have first been shown to and approved by the judges appointed to consider these matters, and by the guardians of the law. And these people have effectively been appointed by us already when we selected lawgivers concerned with music, and our supervisor of education. Well then, to repeat my question, shall we lay this down as a third model or aspect of our law? What do you think?

Clinias: Do so, indeed.

801e

Athenian: After these issues are settled, the right thing to do would be to sing hymns and praises to the gods, combined with prayers, and then, in like manner, prayers and praises to the daimons and the heroes, as appropriate to each.

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: And after this there could be no objections to an immediate law whereby praises may be properly sung for any citizens approaching life's end, who have noble achievements to show for their hard work, physical or mental, and who have been obedient to the laws.

Clinias: How could anyone object?

802a

Athenian: As for those who are still alive, it is not safe to honour them with praises and hymns until their entire life has run its course and has attained a noble end. Then all these honours may be allowed to men and to women, without distinction, who have been conspicuous for their goodness. As for the songs and the dances, these should be organised as follows. Among the works of the ancients there are many beautiful traditional musical compositions, and the same may

be said of dances too for our bodies. And we are free to select from these whatever is appropriate and suitable for the constitution we are establishing. To make the selection, scrutinisers of these poems and dances are to be chosen who are more than fifty years of age. Whatever works of the ancients are deemed satisfactory should be accepted, while those deemed deficient or totally unsuitable are to be either rejected out of hand, or revised and corrected, as the case may be. For this we shall employ the services of the musical and poetical folk, making use of their ability as composers without surrendering to their tastes and preferences, with rare exceptions. Rather, by interpreting the wishes of the lawgiver, we shall institute dancing, singing and choral performance in general, as much in accord with those overall intentions as possible.

802c

Athenian: Any disordered musical activity is improved a thousandfold once it is regulated, even without the addition of the honey-sweet Muse. Pleasure is a common feature of all kinds of music. For someone who has lived his life from his earliest childhood until the age of maturity and good sense in the presence of a sober and measured style of music hates the opposite style when he hears it, and declares it to be unworthy of a free people. But someone who is brought up on popular sweet music regards the opposite style as cold and joyless. And so, as I said just now, neither the pleasure nor the joylessness has prevailed in either case, but the styles differ insofar as one makes those who are brought up on it better, while the other makes them worse.

Clinias: You have expressed that very well.

802e

Athenian: It would be necessary, in addition, to make a rough division, distinguishing between songs suited to females and those suited to males, and it would be important to set them to

appropriate harmonies and rhythms. Indeed, it would be terrible for the overall harmony, and the rhythms too, to be discordant, because the songs are not assigned what is suitable and appropriate in each case. So it will be necessary to legislate on these matters, at least in general terms. Now, although it is possible to assign the required harmony and rhythm to both kinds of songs, what songs are assigned to the female should be determined by the actual distinction between the natures of the sexes. Whatever is exalted and inclines towards courage should be pronounced manly, while anything that tends more towards order and sound-mindedness should, by our tradition of language and of law, be regarded as more feminine. This then is the arrangement. After this, we shall speak of teaching and passing on these subjects, the manner in which this is to be done in each case, to whom, and when. I seem to be behaving much like a shipbuilder who begins his design by laying down the keel and sketching the vessel in general outline. I am trying to set various lives before you in various terms, based upon the manner of people's souls, actually laying down their keels, to give proper consideration to this important question: how may we best navigate this journey of life? By what manner or means of living is this to be done? Now, human affairs are not worthy of extreme seriousness, but be serious we must, more's the pity. Yet, since we are here in this world, if we were somehow or other to be serious in an appropriate way, that would probably be the right measure for us. But what precisely do I mean? Someone would probably challenge me with that question, and rightly so.

Clinias: Indeed so.

803c

Athenian: I maintain that we should take what's serious seriously, and not be serious about what's trivial. God is naturally worthy of the utmost beneficent seriousness, while

humans, as I said before, have been constructed as a plaything of God, and that really is what's best about us. Every man and woman then should live their lives accordingly, adopting this way of living by playing the game as beautifully as they can, in total contrast to their present attitude.

Clinias: How so?

803d

Athenian: Nowadays they are of the view, it seems, that anything serious should be undertaken with play as the objective. And so, they believe that warfare, being a serious business, should properly be undertaken for the sake of peace. But the fact is that in warfare there never has been any play, nor indeed any education worth mentioning, nor is there now, nor will there ever be, and this I maintain is the most serious issue for us. So each of us should spend our lives, for the most part, in peace and excellence. What, then, is the right way to do this? Our lives are to be lived playing certain games which involve performing sacrifices, singing hymns, and dancing, so as to be able to secure the favour of the gods, and, indeed, repel our enemies and defeat them in battle. By what sorts of singing and dancing may both these objectives be attained? This has already been answered in broad outline, and the path has, in a sense, been opened up for us to tread, confident that the poet was right to say: "Telemachos, some of it you yourself will see in your own heart, and some the divinity will put in your mind. I do not think you could have been born and reared without the gods' will."⁸⁴ So, our charges too should be of the same mind as the poet; they must accept that what has been said is sufficient, and that in the case of sacrifices and dances, the daimon and god will make suggestions as to the particular gods to whom they are to offer their games in propitiation. And so, they will live out their lives in accord with the sort of nature they possess, being for the most part puppets, occasionally getting a

glimpse of the truth.

804b

Megillus: You are belittling the human race mightily, stranger.

Athenian: Do not be surprised, Megillus, just forgive me. I was intent upon God just now, and I said what I said in the light of that experience. So, if you prefer, let us allow that this human race of ours is not lowly, but deserves to be taken seriously.

804c

Athenian: To continue with the original subject, we spoke of buildings for public gymnasia and schools, three of them in the centre of the city, and, indeed, three training grounds and open spaces for horses outside the city on the periphery, fitted out for instructing and training the young in archery and long-range warfare in general. And if it turns out that these were not described in sufficient detail earlier, let us incorporate them now into our argument and laws. In all these places there are to be teachers in residence for each subject, foreigners attracted by the pay to teach any subjects that are concerned with warfare, or, indeed, with music, to those who attend. And it is not that the children are to attend if their father so wishes, and be exempt from the education if he does not. No, if possible, every "man and boy", as they say, being children of the city more so than of their parents, has to be educated. And, indeed, in the case of females, my law would mandate the very same provision as for males; the training of males and females should be identical. And in stating this argument, I have no reservations about horsemanship and gymnastics being appropriate for men but not for women. In fact, I have been convinced of this by hearing time-old stories, and nowadays I know that there are, so to speak, thousands and thousands of women living around the Black Sea – Sarmatian women, they are called – who have been directed to get involved to the same extent as the men, not only in horsemanship but in archery and

the use of weapons generally, and they train to the very same extent. Besides, I have a particular viewpoint on these issues, as follows. If it really is possible to arrange matters in this way, then the current practice in our parts of the world is the height of folly. It is sheer folly that all men and women don't conspire, with all their might, to engage in the same pursuits. As matters stand, almost every city turns out, more or less, to be only half what it might be, based upon the same expenditure and effort. And that, surely, constitutes an astonishing error on the part of the lawgiver.

805c

Clinias: So it seems, stranger. Nevertheless, much of what is now being suggested runs counter to our customary civic practices. You said that the argument should be allowed to run its course and we should draw conclusions only when it is over. That suggestion was most reasonable, and I must rebuke myself for saying what I have just said. So, proceed with the argument as you think best.

Athenian: Well, Clinias, what seems best to me is what I said previously; if current practices did not provide sufficient evidence that these proposals can actually be implemented, perhaps it might have been possible to contradict the argument. But now someone who won't accept this law of ours must pursue a different course, and our injunction will not be nullified by these arguments. The female sex must share, as much as possible, with the male sex both in education and in everything else. And, indeed, this somehow is the way in which we need to think about these issues. Suppose that women do not participate in common with men in every aspect of their lives, won't we need to make some different arrangements for them?

Clinias: Yes, we would need to do that.

805e

Athenian: If we had to pick some arrangement that is currently established somewhere in preference to this common participation that we are now imposing on them, which arrangement would we choose? Would it be the system used by the Thracians and many other peoples whereby their womenfolk tend the land, mind the oxen and sheep, perform menial tasks, and are not much different from slaves? Or should we do as all of us do in our region? Among ourselves nowadays, our practice on these issues is as follows. We accumulate all of our wealth under one roof, so called, and to the women we hand over the management of provisions and responsibility for weaving and wool-working in general. Or should we propose the middle ground, Megillus, the Spartan approach? Are the young girls to be involved in gymnastics and music too, while the women, although excused from wool-working, weave for themselves a busy life that is not at all commonplace or paltry, reaching a middle ground consisting of service, management of provisions and child-rearing, without having any involvement in warfare? So, if some necessity ever arises to do battle on behalf of the city and its children, are they to be unable to use a bow skilfully like the Amazons can, or use any other kind of projectile either? Could they even imitate the goddess⁸⁵ by picking up a shield and spear, taking a noble stand against the devastation of their native land, and be able, at very least, to strike fear into their enemies by being seen in battle formation? Based upon their manner of living, they could never attempt to imitate the Sarmatian Amazons at all; alongside your women, those women would look like men. So, if anyone wishes to sing the praises of your lawgivers, let him do so. For my part, I can only say what I have just said: the lawgiver is to be fully committed and not half do the job by allowing the female sex a luxurious, profligate and disorderly lifestyle, while paying close attention to the male sex, thus endowing the city with just half of a completely happy life, rather than the whole thing.

806c

Megillus: What are we to do, Clinias? Shall we allow the stranger to denigrate Sparta in our presence in this way?

806d

Clinias: Yes. Having granted him freedom of speech we must allow him free rein until such time as we have gone through the laws in sufficient detail.

Megillus: You're right.

Athenian: What comes next? Shall I now try to tell you?

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: What sort of life, then, would people have if all their needs were met in due measure, all skilled labour had been handed over to others, and their farms had been entrusted to slaves, yielding a return sufficient for people who live orderly lives? What if communal meals were arranged, with men eating apart, while members of their household dined close by, including female children and their mothers? Suppose supervisors, male and female, were appointed to break up the gatherings on each occasion, having kept the conduct of the meals under observation, ensuring that everyone went on their way, in due course and order, after the supervisor and the others had poured a libation to the gods to whom that day and night happened to be sacred. For people living under such arrangements, what necessary work is there? What work is really appropriate? Is each of them to spend their life like a fatted beast? No, that, I maintain, is neither just nor noble, nor could someone living in this way fail to get what is due to him, and what is due to an idle creature, fattening itself in indolence, is generally to fall prey to some other creature, one that has been worn thin by vigorous hard work.

807a

Athenian: Now, if we sought to implement these measures, as now described properly in detail, they would probably never see the light of day as long as there are private wives, children and dwellings, and everything of this sort is arranged on a private basis for each and every one of us. But if, instead, we could implement the second-best arrangements, the ones we are describing, that would be most reasonable. And yet, we maintain that for people living in this way, the task entrusted to them is far from trivial or commonplace; a just law has assigned them the most important task of all.

807b

Athenian: Consider, then, a life that affords no leisure for any other activities at all, the life of someone intent upon victory in the Olympic or Pythian games, for instance. Well, the life that is concerned with the overall care of both body and soul in terms of excellence, the one that may most truly be called a life, is twice – indeed, more than twice – as busy. Indeed, no other tasks should act as a distraction, impeding the provision of the appropriate exercise and nutriment to the body, or, indeed, of the necessary instruction and habituation to the soul. All day and all night is scarcely enough for someone engaged in this task to derive full and complete benefit from these pursuits. And this being the case, all these free people should have a regulated lifestyle all of the time, beginning more or less at dawn on one day and continuing without any interruption until dawn and sunrise on the next. Now, any lawgiver who makes lots of detailed trivial pronouncements about private domestic arrangements would be a sorry sight, especially when these are concerned with how long people should remain awake at night if they are to be accomplished and attentive guardians of the entire city. Indeed, for any of our citizens to spend the whole of any night in slumber, and not be seen wide awake by his entire household because he got up first, should be regarded by everyone as disgraceful and unworthy of a free people, whether

such behaviour is dictated by law or by practice. And, indeed, for the lady of the house to be awakened by some attendants rather than herself wakening everyone else first should be proclaimed a disgrace among the servants themselves, male and female, young and old, and even, if possible, by the very building itself. A good proportion of civic and household affairs should be dealt with whilst awake during the night hours by those in authority in the city, and by masters and mistresses in private households. For a lot of sleep is not naturally suitable either for our bodies or for our souls, or, indeed, when dealing with all these affairs. No one who is asleep is good for anything, any more than a dead person. But those of us who care most for being alive and using our minds, remain awake as much as we can, making sure that we get only as much sleep as is needed for our health, and that is not much once the habit has been well established. When the rulers in cities are awake during the night hours, they strike fear into evil doers, be they external enemies or fellow citizens, yet they are admired and respected by the just, sound-minded people, and are a source of benefit to themselves and to the city in its entirety.

808d

Athenian: In addition to all the benefits we have listed, spending the night in this way will also equip the souls of everyone who resides in these cities with some courage. And when day breaks once again at dawn, the children make their way to their teachers, for children should not be allowed to live without someone in charge of them, nor slaves without masters, any more than sheep or any other beast should be without herdsmen. Of all beasts, the young child is the most difficult to take in hand, since the fact that he, in particular, possesses a fount of intelligence that is as yet uncontrolled makes him a scheming, shrewd and extremely unruly creature. That is why a child needs to be reined in by lots of bridles, as it were, firstly, when he is away from his nurse and his mother, by attendants

to deal with his childish immaturity; then by teachers of any subjects at all, and by instruction that befits a free people. And yet he must also be treated as a slave who may be punished by any free man who comes across the child himself, or his attendant or teacher, engaging in any transgression. What is more, if the person who comes across them fails to inflict a just punishment, he is first and foremost to be held in the utmost contempt. Then the guardian of the law who has been put in charge of the children shall keep a close eye on this person who came across the transgression we are referring to and did not impose the required punishment or did so in an improper manner. This guardian of ours should be extremely vigilant, pay particular attention to the rearing of the children, and guide their development by constantly turning them towards what is good and lawful.

809b

Athenian: As for the guardian himself, how might this law of ours provide him with adequate instruction? As matters stand, it has not so far said anything that is sufficiently clear; some issues have been dealt with, others not. But in the case of this man, the law should do its best to omit nothing and expound a full account so that he in turn may expound this to others and look after them. The types of choral performances, by which we mean songs and dances, which should be selected, corrected and consecrated, have already been dealt with. But, O most excellent overseer of children, we have not described the kinds of written compositions, devoid of metre, to be used by your charges, and the manner in which they should be used. Now, you already have an account of what they should learn and study in relation to warfare. Then there are letters and the lyre, and also calculation, of which we said there should be as much as each person needs to learn for the purposes of warfare, household management and the administration of the city. For the same reasons, they should also learn whatever is useful

concerning the orbits of the heavenly bodies, the sun, moon and stars, and any provisions that any city needs to make with reference to these. What I am referring to is the arrangement of the days into cycles of months, and the months into each recurring year, so that seasons, sacrifices and festivals are each celebrated in accord with the natural order because they have each been assigned their own appropriate place. These keep the city alive and alert, bestow honours upon its gods, and render the people more intelligent about these matters. These issues have not so far been adequately explained to you by the lawgiver, my friend. So pay attention to what is to be said next.

809e

Athenian: Now, in the first place, we are saying that you have not had adequate instruction about the written word. What is our objection? It is this: it has not yet been explained to you whether someone who is to be a reasonable citizen is to go into the subject in detail or set it aside entirely, and the same consideration applies to playing the lyre. Well, we are now saying that these studies should not be set aside. For a ten-year-old, three years on writing is more or less enough, and if he takes up the lyre at the age of thirteen, three years is a good measure of time to spend on it. And neither the child himself nor his father may be permitted to prolong or curtail the time spent on these subjects out of love or distaste for them, and go against the law by so doing. Whoever does not comply is to be deprived of the educational honours which we shall describe shortly.

810b

Athenian: You should first understand what precisely the young people should learn in those years, and, again, what the teachers should teach. And we should not insist upon high achievement, in terms of speed or beauty, in students whose development is naturally slower during the specified time periods. For the purpose of instruction in written compositions

not set to music, some having metre, others devoid of rhythmical subdivisions, consisting in fact of the spoken word alone, bereft of rhythm and harmony; for this purpose we have been left writings that are fraught with danger by some of the numerous authors of this kind. So, most excellent guardians of the law, what are you to do with these? And what exact directions for using them would the lawgiver give you if he were to proceed aright? I think this will challenge him mightily.

810c

Clinias: What exactly do you mean, stranger? You are apparently describing your own personal perplexity.

Athenian: Your suspicion is correct, Clinias, and, indeed, since the two of you are my partners in this discussion of laws, I need to explain where the difficulties seem to lie and where they do not.

Clinias: Well then, what point are you making now, and what is bothering you?

Athenian: I will tell you, then, although it is not at all easy to speak in opposition to tens of thousands of voices.

Clinias: What's this? Do you think that what we have said already about laws goes against majority opinion, merely on a few insignificant matters?

810d

Athenian: Very true, in fact you seem to be telling me, as I see it, that although the same course is anathema to the majority, it is perhaps acceptable to just as many others, and even if there are fewer of them, they are every bit as good as the majority. You are now encouraging me to take my chances with these few, not to give up, but proceed courageously along the legislative course prescribed by our present arguments.

Clinias: Indeed.

810e

Athenian: I shall not give up, then. Now, I am saying that we have countless poets who compose in hexameters, in trimeters, and in all the metrical forms you could mention, some whose intention is serious, others intent upon raising a laugh. The tens of thousands of voices maintain that properly educated young people should be brought up on these verses and saturated in them, thus turning them into highly learned folk who have heard a lot, having committed entire poems to memory. There are others who select highlights from all the poets' works, compile whole extracts, and maintain that these must be studied and committed to memory if our young charge is to be good and wise, because of this extensive experience and learning. Are you telling me, then, to be frank with these people and point out the rights and wrongs of what they are saying?

Clinias: Of course.

811b

Athenian: Well then, is there a single statement I can make about all of these poets that will suffice? I think that something along the following lines may be enough, something on which most people will agree with me. Each of these poets has said much that is good and much that is not. If this is the case, then I maintain that for children, extensive learning is fraught with danger.

Clinias: So what advice would you give to the guardian of the law?

Athenian: About what?

811c

Clinias: About the guideline he is to refer to as to what all the young folk should be allowed to learn and what should be forbidden. Tell us and hold nothing back.

Athenian: Good man, Clinias, I suspect that I have somehow been fortunate.

Clinias: In what respect?

811d

Athenian: Insofar as I am not entirely at a loss for a standard. In fact, as I look back now at the discussions we have conducted from dawn up to this point, not, I believe, without some inspiration from the gods, these seem to me to have been delivered from start to finish like some poem. Indeed, as I surveyed our own arguments, gathered together as it were, it is surely no surprise that I experienced great delight. In fact, of all the many discourses I have learned or listened to, in poetry or in a flood of words like ours, these to me are evidently the most measured, and especially appropriate for young people to hear. So I don't think I would be able to propose a better standard than this to an educator and guardian of the law, or do better than encourage him to instruct those who teach children, to teach them these discourses. And if in his enquiries he should somehow come across poetical compositions that are related to or similar to these, in the form of prose writings or simple unwritten works, akin to these discourses, he is not to let them go at all, but get them written down. Firstly, he is to compel the teachers themselves to learn and to praise these, and any of the teachers who don't like them are not to be employed as colleagues, while those who go along with his praise are to be employed and entrusted with the instruction and education of the young. And so, with this, let my story about the written word and the teachers thereof be concluded.

812a

Clinias: Well, stranger, looking at our initial intention, I don't think we have gone outside of the bounds of the discussions we intended. But it is hard to say for certain whether we are still adopting the correct approach or not.

Athenian: That, dear Clinias, as we have said on many occasions, is likely to become clearer of itself once we come to

the end of our entire exposition concerning laws.

Clinias: You're right.

812b

Athenian: So, after the teacher of the written word, shouldn't we deal next with the harp teacher?

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: Well then, in the case of harp teachers, I think we shall assign them their appropriate roles as instructors and as educators in such subjects generally, if we bring our previous discussions to mind.

Clinias: Discussions about what?

812c

Athenian: We said, I believe, that the sixty-year-old singers of the chorus of Dionysus have to be exceptionally perceptive in relation both to the rhythms and to the constructions of the harmonies in melodic imitations, which may be good or bad in terms of how they affect the soul. This will ensure that there is someone who can distinguish between the likenesses associated with a good imitation and those of a bad one, reject the latter, give pride of place to the former, and sing these to the young folk to charm their souls, encouraging each of them to hold fast to the acquisition of excellence which they should understand by means of the imitations.

Clinias: Very true.

812d

Athenian: To this end, the harp teacher and the student should make use of its sounds for the sake of the distinctness of its strings by matching the notes of the instrument to those of the voice. But the harp exhibits contrast and variation, so that one tune comes from the strings, another from the composer of the melody, especially when lots of notes are sounded with very few, fast tempo with slow, high pitch with low, and likewise all

sorts of variations in rhythm can be incorporated into the notes of the harp. All such devices are to be avoided if our pupils are to derive benefit from music in the short space of three years. For this clash of opposites with one another makes learning difficult, but it is most important that our young people learn easily. Indeed, the compulsory subjects we are assigning to them are neither few nor trivial, but the progress of our discussion will reveal these in due course. So, our educator is to look after these matters for us in this way. As for the musical compositions themselves, and the words that the choral instructors should teach, and what these should be like, all this we have already described in detail. We stated that they should each be consecrated and assigned to the appropriate festival, thus benefiting the cities by providing them with propitious pleasure.

Clinias: True. You have explained this.

813b

Athenian: True, indeed. And our chosen supervisor of music is to assume responsibility for this, and may good fortune attend him. Our contribution will be to add to what has already been said about dance and physical training in general. Just as in the case of musical instruction we contributed what was missing, so we should also do the very same in the case of physical training. For the children, male and female, must indeed learn to dance and to train their bodies. Isn't this so?

Clinias: Yes.

Athenian: The boys and the girls should have dancing teachers, male and female, so that this exercise may be of service to them.

Clinias: They should.

813c

Athenian: Then let us call once again upon the person who will have most duties to perform, the one in charge of our children,

who, being responsible for both musical and physical training, will be very busy indeed.

Clinias: How will he be able, at his age, to be responsible for so much?

813d

Athenian: Easily enough, my friend. For in exercising this responsibility, the law has given him, and will always give him, the support of any of the citizens, male or female, whom he wishes to enlist. And he will know the people he needs, and will resolve to make no error in selecting them because he has the intelligence to recognise and respect the importance of his own role, and come to the realisation that when the young have been, and continue to be, well brought up, everything holds to a steady course for us. But if not, the consequences should not even be spoken of, and we are not to speak of them now in the case of our new city out of respect for those who are highly superstitious. On these matters too, concerning dancing, and movement related to bodily exercises in general, we have said a great deal already.

813e

Athenian: For we are instituting gymnasia and the various bodily exercises related to warfare: archery, throwing missiles, skirmishing, all sorts of armour fighting, tactical manoeuvres, various marches of armies and encampments, and the subjects involved in cavalry training. Indeed, there should be public instructors in all these, earning a wage from the city, and their pupils should be the boys and men of the city. And the girls, and women too, must be knowledgeable about all these matters, having practised dancing and fighting in armour while still young, and in womanhood having taken part in manoeuvres, drills, and the placing and taking up of arms. If nothing else, this will ensure that if it ever proves necessary for our entire fighting force to leave the city on military campaign, those who

are left guarding the children and the city at large, will at least be up to the task. Or if, on the other hand, and this is nothing unusual, some external enemy, Greek or barbarian, were to invade with huge power and might, and there had to be a battle for the city itself, it would presumably be a vile disgrace to the state if the women had been so badly brought up that they were not prepared to do as birds do and fight for their young against the strongest of beasts in the face of death and all sorts of dangers, but instead they made straight for refuge in the temples, crowding all the shrines and altars, pouring upon human beings the reputation for being the most cowardly creatures of all.

814c

Clinias: No, by Zeus, stranger. If this were to happen in the city, apart from the harm it would do, it would be most unseemly.

Athenian: Should we enact a law to this effect – that to the extent indicated at least, women are not to neglect military matters, but all citizens, male and female, are to attend to them?

Clinias: Well, I agree with you at any rate.

814d

Athenian: Now, as for wrestling, much has been said, but I would maintain that we have not yet dealt with its most important aspect, nor is it easy to do so without a physical demonstration to illustrate what is being said. So, we shall only make a decision on this when word follows deed and makes something about the various issues we have spoken of quite clear – that of all movements, the sort of wrestling we are referring to is very closely related to military combat, and, indeed, the wrestling should be pursued for the sake of the combat, and not the other way around.

Clinias: You are right about that anyway.

814e

Athenian: Let that be enough said for now on the efficacy of wrestling. Movement of the entire body, other than in wrestling, may, for the most part, properly be described as dancing. We should think of this as having two forms, one being the dignified representation of the movement of beautiful bodies, the other being the base representation of the motion of ugly bodies. And again, the base and the serious movements have two further subdivisions. One form of the serious movement occurs in warfare and in the strenuous exertions of beautiful bodies and a courageous soul, the other is the motion of a moderate soul in success, amidst measured pleasures, and this would naturally be called the dance of peace. The warlike kind, which is quite different from the peaceful one, may properly be referred to as Pyrrhic. This imitates various means of avoiding blows and missiles by ducking, yielding, jumping upwards, and by crouching, and their opposites too, motions that involve postures of attack, attempting to imitate the shooting of arrows and darts and the inflicting of all sorts of blows. In these dances, the upright and well-braced posture, when imitating the good bodies and souls, preserving for the most part the straightness of the limbs of the body, is the sort of imitation we accept as correct, while imitations of the opposite of these are wrong. In the case of the peace dance, the following question needs to be considered in each case. Does the performer, in his dances, succeed or fail in persistently adopting the noble dancing in a manner appropriate to people with good laws?

815c

Athenian: So we have, in the first place, to make a distinction between controversial dancing and the uncontroversial kind. What, then, is this distinction, and how may we distinguish one kind from the other? Any Bacchic dances, or those of that ilk, which, as they say, mimic so-called nymphs, pans, sileni and

satyrs in a drunken state, which are performed during certain purifications or initiations, all constitute a class of dancing that defies easy definition as a peace dance or a war dance, nor is its purpose easy to define. I think that the most correct way to distinguish this dance is to insist that it is distinct from the warlike and the peaceful kinds, declare this dance to be uncivilised, leave it aside, and return once more to the warlike and peaceful dances which are, undeniably, ours. Whatever belongs to the non-warlike Muse, dances in which people revere the gods and their offspring, constitutes a single general class involving a sense of well-being. This may be divided into two parts. One imitates people escaping from hardships and dangers and coming out well. This is more pleasurable. The other is milder in its pleasures, and it involves the preservation or increase of goods that they already possess. And in these situations, presumably, a person moves more violently when the pleasures are greater, and less violently when they are less. Again, someone who is better behaved and better trained for courage moves less violently, while the coward, and someone untrained for restraint, exhibits more violent and erratic changes in his movements. In general, when the voice is being used, whether in song or in speech, no one is able to keep the body totally still. And so, because there is imitation, in gesture, of whatever is spoken, this has produced the art of dancing in its entirety. In all these situations, some of us move in harmony with the utterances, others do not. Now, many of our other traditional names should be given well-deserved praise for their excellence and their accord with nature. One of these is the name given to the dances of people who are doing well and are themselves measured in their use of pleasure. See how right the man was, and how musical too, whoever he was, who, with good reason, named all these dances "harmonious" and established two kinds of noble dances, one warlike, called "pyrrhic", the other one peaceful, called "harmonious". He gave a suitable and

fitting name to both. These the lawgiver should explain in general terms, while the legal guardian should scrutinise them, and having completed his investigation, combine dance with music in general, and allocate to the various sacrificial festivals whatever is appropriate to each, thus consecrating them all in due order. Thereafter, there should be no change in anything involving dance or song. And so, the same city and body of citizens should live well and live happily, being as like unto one another as possible by enjoying the same pleasures in the same way.

816c

Athenian: So, that concludes the matter of beautiful bodies and noble souls engaged in choral performances of the kind we have prescribed. But we also need to look at and take note of ill-formed bodies and ill-formed notions, and those who engage in laughable clownish activity in speech, song or dance, using imitations of all these for comic effect. For it is not possible to understand the serious without considering the comic, or to understand anything that has an opposite in the absence of its own opposite if we propose to develop our intelligence. Nor indeed is it possible to engage in both if we really intend to share even in a modicum of excellence. No, the very reason why we need to understand these is to ensure that we never do or say ridiculous things out of ignorance when we shouldn't. But such mimicry is to be turned over to slaves and foreign hirelings, and it should never be taken seriously. Nor should any free-born man or woman ever be seen engaging in its study, and there should always be something novel about these imitative performances. So much then for the laughable entertainment which we generally call comedy. It may be settled in this way by law and by reason.

817a

Athenian: As for the so-called serious compositions of the tragic poets, suppose some of them were to approach us and

question us. "Strangers, may we or may we not visit your city and its territory, and may we bring our poetry along with us, or how have you decided to deal with such matters?" How might we respond to these divine men in the right way on these issues? I suggest the following. "Visitors, best of men, we ourselves are authors of a tragedy, the most beautiful and excellent one we are capable of. Indeed, our entire civic arrangement has been constructed as an imitation of the most beautiful and excellent life, which, at least according to us, really is the truest tragedy. So you are poets and we are poets too, of the same sort, rival authors and rival actors in the most beautiful drama, which true law alone naturally produces. That is what we believe. Do not presume then that we shall ever allow you so easily to set up your stage in our midst in our market place, bringing in your honey-voiced actors to drown out our sound, or trust you to speak publicly to our women and children and the general populace, speaking on the same topics we speak on, not saying the same things as we do, but for the most part, the complete opposite. In fact, we would be completely mad, more or less, and so would any city that would allow you to do what is now being suggested, before the officials had decided whether or not your works are fit to be spoken and deserve a hearing among us. Well then, ye children sprung from the soft Muses, once you have, in the first place, exhibited your own verses to the officials alongside ours, then provided your pronouncements turn out to be every bit as good as ours or even better, we shall grant you a public chorus. But if not, my friends, we could never do so. So, if you agree, in the case of choral performance in general, and instruction in these matters, let these customs be prescribed to accompany the laws, one set of arrangements for slaves, a different set for their masters."

817e

Clinias: How could we disagree, at this stage at least?

Athenian: For a free people there are three subjects still remaining: calculation and whatever involves number, one subject; measurement of length, area and volume is the second one; while the third deals with the orbit of the stars, and their natural motion relative to one another. It is not necessary for a lot of people to apply themselves to all these subjects in all their detail. Only a few should do so. And we shall say who these people are as we come to the end. That's the appropriate place. It would be appropriate for the multitude to learn as much of these subjects as is necessary, and it would be a disgrace, properly speaking, for most people not to know that much at least. But for everyone to study them in detail would neither be easy, nor at all practicable. Yet, what is necessary in them cannot be cast aside, and it seems that whoever first devised the proverb about God had these in view when he said that not even God would ever be seen doing battle against necessity, referring, I believe, to necessities that are divine. Since, if the reference is to human necessities, which is what most people have in mind when they say this sort of thing, then this is by far one of the silliest of all sayings.

818b

Clinias: What, stranger, are the necessities in these subjects that are not of this human sort, the divine ones?

818c

Athenian: In my opinion they are those which, if they neither enacted nor learned them at all, no god would be a god to humanity, nor would any daimon or hero be capable of exercising any serious care of us humans. They would fall far short of the status even of a godly human if they were completely unable to tell one from two or two from three or, in general, distinguish odd from even, or did not know how to count at all and were unable to demarcate night and day, having no familiarity with the orbits of the sun and the moon and the other stars. So all these studies are necessary for anyone who

intends to attain any knowledge whatsoever of the most exalted of subjects, and it is utter folly to think otherwise. The particular aspects of these that should be studied, the extent and timing of this, what goes with what, which may be studied in isolation, and all combinations of these, this is what needs to be understood first. We may then proceed, guided by these subjects, to learn the others. For necessity has settled matters in this way, and against this we maintain none of the gods now does battle, nor will they ever do so.

818e

Clinias: It seems at the moment, stranger, when you put it like that, that this has been expressed correctly and that what you are saying is in accordance with nature.

Athenian: This is indeed the case, Clinias, yet although we have prearranged matters in this way, it is difficult just now to enact any laws. But we might, if you agree, enact laws in greater detail on some other occasion.

Clinias: You seem to us, stranger, to be concerned about the customary lack of experience in these subjects among ourselves. But your fear is ill-founded, so try to explain yourself without any reservation on those grounds.

819a

Athenian: Although I have concerns on the grounds you mention, I am even more fearful of those who apply themselves to these particular subjects but do so in the wrong way. Complete and total inexperience is never a threat, nor is it a huge evil, but vast experience and learning, accompanied by bad training, is much more damaging.

Clinias: True.

819b

Athenian: So I maintain that free people should learn as much of these various subjects as vast hordes of children in Egypt

learn when they are being taught to write. For beginning with calculation, lessons have been devised for mere children, combining amusement and pleasure with learning. They make distributions of some apples or garlands, allocating the same fixed number to larger or smaller groups, or they arrange byes and pairings for boxers and wrestlers, who take their turn in sequence as natural circumstances dictate. And, indeed, they devise games in which saucers of gold, bronze and silver and other such materials are mixed, or in other cases whole sets of these are distributed. By fitting the applications of the rules of arithmetic into a game, as I said, they are of benefit to the students in terms of the arranging, leading and marching of armies, and in household affairs too, and so they produce people who are generally more useful to themselves and more alert. After this, in the case of measurements of distance, area, and volume, they dispel the natural but laughable and shameful ignorance about all these matters that is so widely prevalent.

Clinias: What do you mean? What sort of ignorance?

819d

Athenian: Dear Clinias, when I heard only recently of our general predicament in relation to these matters, I was astonished, and it seemed to me more like the predicament not of humans, but of lowly creatures like pigs, and I was ashamed not only for myself, but for the entire Greek world.

Clinias: About what? Tell us what you mean, stranger.

Athenian: I am telling you, but I will make the point clearer by using questions. Tell me briefly, do you know what length is?

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: What about area?

Clinias: Absolutely.

Athenian: Do you realise that these are two distinct things and that volume is a third?

Clinias: Certainly.

Athenian: Now, do you think that all these can be measured against one another?

Clinias: Yes.

Athenian: I mean, that length can naturally be measured against length, area against area, and the same applies to volume.

Clinias: Very much so.

819e

Athenian: But what if this is neither very much so nor moderately so, but so in some cases and not so in others, and you believe that it is so in all cases? How then, would you rate your understanding of these matters?

Clinias: I'd rate it badly, of course.

Athenian: Now, what about length and area with respect to volume, or length and area with respect to one another? Aren't we Greeks all of the view that they can somehow or other be measured against one another?

Clinias: Entirely so.

820a

Athenian: But if this is not possible in any way at all, but we Greeks, as I said, are of the view that it is possible, are we not justified, out of shame on behalf of us all, in saying to them, "Oh most excellent Greeks, this is one of those matters of which we said that ignorance constitutes disgrace, although there is nothing particularly wonderful in knowledge of such necessary matters either."

Clinias: Of course.

820c

Athenian: And besides these, there are other matters related to these in which, again, many errors akin to these errors arise for us.

Clinias: Such as?

Athenian: Issues concerning the nature of the interrelationship of things that are measurable against one another and things that are not. In fact, we need to be able to distinguish between these or else be very lowly creatures indeed. People should be constantly setting problems like this for one another, competing in activities that are valuable to them, a much more refined pastime for old men than draughts.

Clinias: Perhaps. After all, there is not a great deal of difference between draughts and these subjects.

820d

Athenian: Well, Clinias, I maintain that the young folk should learn these subjects. Indeed, they are neither harmful nor difficult, and when learned through the medium of play they will benefit the city and do it no harm. Yet if anyone says otherwise, we should listen to him.

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: Well then, if this turns out to be how matters stand with these subjects, we should obviously include them in our scheme, but if this is not the case they should be excluded.

Clinias: Obviously, indeed.

820e

Athenian: In that case, stranger, shall we now let these be included among the subjects that need to be learned so that there may be no gaps in our laws? But let us let them lie there like so many pledges that can be revoked from the rest of the constitution, in case we who have given them or you who are receiving them come to disapprove of them.

Clinias: A fair pledge.

Athenian: Next we should consider teaching the young people about the stars, and whether you approve of this or not.

Clinias: Proceed.

Athenian: There is a major surprise in relation to these matters, a totally intolerable one.

Clinias: What is it?

821a

Athenian: We maintain, nowadays, that the greatest god and the entire universe should not be subject to enquiry, nor should we busy ourselves in seeking out their causes, because to do so is an unholy act. But it does seem that the very opposite course of action to this is the correct course.

Clinias: What do you mean?

821b

Athenian: What I am saying is controversial and may be thought inappropriate to men of our advanced years. However, once a person believes a particular teaching to be exalted, true, beneficial to the city, and favoured completely by God, it is no longer at all possible for him to refrain from speaking about it.

Clinias: Quite likely. But what teaching concerning the stars shall we find that matches your description?

Athenian: Good friends, nowadays all Greeks are, in a sense, telling a lie about the great gods – the Sun and the Moon.

Clinias: What lie is this?

Athenian: By calling these, and some other heavenly bodies along with them, planets, we are saying that they never hold to the same course.

821c

Clinias: Yes, by Zeus, stranger, that is true. Indeed, in my own lifetime, I myself have often observed that the morning star and evening star, and certain others, never traverse the same course, but wander in all sorts of ways, while the sun and the moon behave in a way that presumably is familiar to us all.

Athenian: That is the very reason, Megillus and Clinias, why I am now maintaining, in relation to the gods of the heaven, that our citizens and our young folk should learn at least enough about all these matters to avoid blasphemy in this regard and speak always with reverence, both when performing sacrifices and when uttering solemn prayers.

821d

Clinias: That's true, provided, firstly, that it is possible for whatever you are speaking of to be learned, and secondly, that anything we are now expressing incorrectly about them will be expressed correctly once we have learned this subject. If this is so, then I agree with you that something like this, something of such importance, must be learned. So you should attempt to explain, comprehensively, that this is indeed how matters stand, while we follow along with you and learn.

821e

Athenian: Well, what I am speaking of is not easy to learn, nor again is it enormously difficult, nor does it involve some huge time period. Here's my evidence. Although I had not heard about these matters in my early years, or long ago, I would nevertheless be able to explain them to you both in a relatively short time, whereas if they were complicated, I, at my age, would never be able to explain them to men of your age.

Clinias: True, but what exactly is this teaching which, according to you, is surprising, yet so appropriate for the young, and unknown to us? Please explain this much about it at least, as clearly as you can.

822a

Athenian: Try I must. For this assertion, best of men, that the moon and the sun and the other stars are wandering planets, in any sense, is incorrect; the exact opposite is the case. Each of them always traverses one and the same circular course, not many, even though each appears to follow many. What is more, the quickest of them is believed, incorrectly, to be the slowest, and the slowest to be the quickest. Now, if this is the natural state of affairs, but we believe otherwise, it's as if we were forming such views about horses racing in the Olympic Games, or about men running long distances, declaring the slowest to be quickest and the quickest to be slowest, and singing our celebratory odes to the loser rather than the winner. I imagine such odes would be misplaced, and not very well received by the competitors, who are, after all, mere humans. Yet nowadays, when we fall into the very same errors about the gods, can we not appreciate that what was incorrect and comical in that example would, in this present case, be no laughing matter at all? It is surely not pleasing to the gods that we are continually perpetuating a lie about them.

Clinias: Very true, if this is indeed how matters stand.

822b

Athenian: Well then, if we can demonstrate that this is how matters stand, then everything of this sort should be learned, thus far at least, but if this cannot be demonstrated, then we should leave them aside. Is this our agreement?

Clinias: It certainly is.

822c

Athenian: Well, at this stage we may declare that our regulations concerning the subjects of education are concluded. So we should now apply our minds, in like manner, to hunting and any other activities of this sort. In fact, the responsibility of a lawgiver seems to involve more than instituting laws and leaving it at that. There is something else, besides the laws,

something that naturally lies somewhere between admonition and laws, something that has come up frequently in our discussions, for instance, in connection with the nurture of very young children. For we are not saying that these matters cannot be formulated, but in formulating them it would be outright folly to imagine that we are enacting laws. So, when the laws and the overall constitution have been written down like this, any praise of a citizen for pre-eminent excellence is deficient when it maintains that a citizen is good merely because he is an exceptional servant of the law who obeys them to the utmost. The praise would be more comprehensive if it said that the best citizen is the one who spends his life, through and through, in obedience to anything the lawgiver has written by way of legislation, praise or censure. This statement in praise of a citizen is the most correct one, and so the real lawgiver should not only write down the laws, but he should also intertwine his views on what is good and what's bad with the details of his laws. And the pre-eminent citizen should uphold these, no less than those that are enforced by legal penalties.

823b

Athenian: But if we were to introduce our present topic as a sort of witness, that might make our meaning clearer. Indeed, hunting is a very complex subject, encompassed more or less by a single name. Hunting of water creatures is multifarious, and so is the hunting of birds, and there are a whole variety of ways of hunting land creatures, not only beasts but humans too, and this form of hunting deserves our attention. It operates in warfare and in hunting based upon friendship, which is sometimes praiseworthy, sometimes the opposite. Capture by kidnappers or armies is also a form of hunting. Now, the lawgiver, when enacting laws about hunting, cannot avoid making these differences clear, nor can he set down legal regulations and directions applicable to every situation with penalties as a deterrent. What, then, should be done about such

matters? The lawgiver should praise or censure the various aspects of hunting with a view to the endeavours of the young and their activities, while the young, for their part, should listen and obey, uninfluenced by the pleasure or the pain that is involved. They should comply more with whatever it is that the lawgiver praises, and be more respectful of that than of any particular legal penalties instituted as a deterrent. After these preliminary remarks, a measured praise and censure of hunting should follow, praising the sort that makes the souls of the young better, and censuring the form that does the opposite.

823d

Athenian: Next we should speak to the young people, addressing to them a prayer. Friends, we pray that no desire or passion for hunting by sea may ever overtake you, nor for angling either, nor for the hunting of water creatures in general, nor for lazy hunting using baskets that work on your behalf whether you are awake or asleep. May you never be overtaken by a longing for piracy, the pursuit of your fellow-man on the high seas, which would turn you into wild and lawless hunters. As for thieving in the countryside or in the city, may the thought never so much as cross your minds. And may none of you young folk be seized by the seductive passion for bird-hunting, which is so unbecoming of a free people. What's left for our competitors, then, is only the hunting and pursuit of land animals. One form of this, night hunting, is for idle men who take it in turns to sleep, and it deserves no praise. It involves just as much rest as exertion, and the wildness and strength of the quarry is overpowered by nets and snares rather than the triumph of a soul that loves exertion. The only kind of hunting left for everyone, and the best kind, is the hunting of four-footed beasts using horses, hounds and their own limbs, where the hunters, those that cultivate a divine courage, overcome all the creatures themselves with their own running, striking and shooting.

824a

Athenian: The discourse we have gone through would constitute our praise and our censure of all these matters. The law would be as follows: no one is to prevent those truly sacred hunters from hunting wherever and however they wish. But no one is ever to allow the night hunter, who puts his faith in nets and snares, to hunt anywhere at all. The bird hunter is not to be hindered in the open countryside or on the mountains, but anyone who comes across him on cultivated land or sacred open countryside is to drive him away. The fisherman is allowed to catch fish anywhere except in harbours, sacred rivers, pools and lakes, except that he may not make the water turbid with plant juices.

824c

Athenian: And now, at this stage, we may declare that all our regulations concerning education have been completed.

Clinias: Well you may say so.

BOOK VIII

828a

Athenian: The next step for us, with the help of the oracles from Delphi, is to arrange and establish by law which sacrifices, offered to which gods, would be better and more agreeable to the city. The timing of these and their number would, for the most part, be largely up to ourselves to legislate.

Clinias: Yes, in the case of their number that is quite likely.

Athenian: Then let us deal with their number first. Let there be no fewer than three hundred and sixty-five festivals, ^{828b} so that there is always at least one official offering a sacrifice on behalf of the city, its people or its property, to some god or daimon. Interpreters, priests, priestesses and prophets are to gather together, along with the guardians of the law, and make appropriate arrangements for whatever the lawgiver has

inevitably omitted. And, indeed, these very people should act as judges of what has actually been omitted. And the law, in fact, ^{828c} will say that there are to be twelve festivals to the twelve gods after whom the twelve tribes would each be named, involving monthly sacrifices offered to each of these gods, with choruses and competitions in music and gymnastics being dedicated, as appropriate, both to the gods themselves and the particular seasons of the year. In the case of the women's festivals, they are to determine those from which men should be excluded and those they may attend. What is more, the rituals associated with the gods of the underworld, and those associated with the gods who should be called heavenly, are to be kept separate and not be mixed together, allocating them by law to the twelfth month, sacred to the god of the underworld, ^{828d} Pluto. And there should be no revulsion among military men towards a god of this sort, who should, rather, be revered as being consistently best for the human race. For I would seriously maintain that communion of soul with body is not better in any way than its dissolution in death. Furthermore, those who are going to make these distinctions in a satisfactory manner need to bear the following facts in mind: no city comparable to ours is to be found nowadays, either in terms of the amount of leisure time afforded, or the availability of life's ^{829a} necessities; and, like an individual human being, the city should live well. And to live happily it is first necessary that we ourselves neither do injustice, nor suffer injustice at the hands of others. The first of these requirements is not hugely difficult, but it is extremely difficult to acquire the ability to suffer no injustice, and it is not possible to have this ability perfectly except by becoming perfectly good. The same principle also applies to the city; if it becomes good, its life is peaceful; if bad, its life is a battle, internally and externally. Since this is more or less how matters stand, everyone should train for warfare, not ^{829b} in time of war, but in time of peace. So a city possessed of

intelligence should conduct military exercises for at least one day each month, or more, as the rulers see fit, paying no heed to the weather, be it hot or cold. Whenever the rulers decide to march them all, men, women ^{829c} and children must go. On other occasions they may call upon only part of the population. They should also be continually devising noble games to accompany the sacrifices so that there may be some festive battles imitating the real-life military battles as best they can. At each of these they should award prizes for victory and for excellence, and they should compose speeches of praise or of censure for one another according to how each person fares in the contests, or, indeed, in life generally, decorating whoever is deemed to be best, and censuring anyone who falls short.

^{829d}

Athenian: Not everyone is to be a composer of such speeches. Firstly, they should be more than fifty years of age, and they should not be the sort of people who have attained an acceptable proficiency in poetry and music but have never performed a single noble or illustrious deed themselves. The compositions of people who are themselves good and who are honoured in the city for the noble works they produce, these are the songs that should be sung, even if they are not naturally musical. The selection of these composers shall lie with the educator and the other guardians of the law, who shall allow them the following privilege: they alone are to be allowed freedom of expression in music. No one else is to have such licence, nor ^{829e} should anyone dare to sing an unapproved song that has not been judged by the guardians of the law, even if it be sweeter than the hymns of Thamyras and Orpheus.⁸⁶ All that are allowed are those that have been duly dedicated to the gods, and those composed by good men, which present censure and praise, and have been adjudged to do so in a measured way. And I say that the same directions relating to military activity and freedom of expression in poetry should apply in like manner to

women and men. The lawgiver should reflect and reason with himself as follows. “Now that my preparations are in place for the city as a whole, what sort of people am I nurturing here? Won’t they be competitors in the greatest conflicts of all, where they will encounter vast numbers of opponents?” “Very much so” would be the correct response. Well then, suppose we were ^{830a} nurturing boxers or all-in-fighters or competitors in some other contests like these, would we go into the actual contest itself without practising fighting with someone else on a daily basis beforehand? Surely if we were boxers, we would have been learning to fight for very many days in advance of the competition, and working hard at imitating all the moves we intended to rely upon when we eventually fought it out for victory, and getting as close as possible, in training, to the real thing. Instead of training gloves, we would wear match gloves so as to practise punching and avoiding punches as best we could. And if we had a major problem finding people to train with, would we be so bold as to hang up a lifeless dummy and practise on that, or would we be afraid that some fools might laugh at us for ^{830b} doing so? And if we were ever devoid of opponents, animate or inanimate, and were on our own without training partners, would that deter us from literally fighting with our own shadows? Or what else, besides shadow-boxing, would you call this sort of practising with your own hands?

^{830c}

Clinias: The very name you gave it, stranger, there isn’t really an alternative.

Athenian: Well then, will the fighting force of our city dare to embark every time upon the greatest of all contests worse prepared than contestants of this sort as they do battle for their lives, their children, their wealth and the entire city? And is the lawgiver to be afraid that these training exercises against one another may seem ridiculous to some? Is he, then, to refrain

from enacting laws requiring military activity, if possible, on a daily basis, at least on a small scale without weapons, directing all training, whether in groups or not, to these ends?

830d

Athenian: Won't he also order exercises of another kind, major and minor, to be held at least once a ^{830e} month, involving various contests with one another throughout the entire territory, in which people compete in capturing certain positions and laying ambushes, thus imitating warfare in every aspect? These trials have a way of revealing who is spirited and who is not, through fighting with actual combat gloves and missiles that are as close as possible to the real thing, ^{831a} making use of weapons that are somewhat dangerous so that their game may not be entirely devoid of fear but involve some threats. Then, by correctly awarding honour to one and dishonour to the other, the lawgiver would enable the entire city to be of service in the true life-long contest. And, indeed, if someone loses his life in the process, the slaying is to be regarded as an accident, and once the killer has been purified in accordance with the law, his hands may be pronounced clean. The lawgiver's view will be that if a few people should perish, others who are just as good will be born to replace them, whereas if fear itself should perish, so to speak, he will not find a test to distinguish the better people from the worse in ^{831b} all such cases, and for the city, that is a far greater evil than the other one.

831b

Clinias: We agree with you, stranger. Measures like these should be enshrined in law, and every city should practise them.

Athenian: Now, do all of us understand the reason why such choristry and competition do not exist at all in cities nowadays, except perhaps on a very small scale? Would we say it is because of the ignorance of the general population and the people who

institute laws for them?

Clinias: Perhaps.

^{831c}

Athenian: Not at all, Clinias, bless you! We should insist that there are two causes that are well capable of bringing this about.

Clinias: What are they?

Athenian: One originates in the passion for wealth, which keeps a person so busy that he cares for nothing else besides his own personal possessions. Once the soul of every citizen depends upon these, it would never be capable of having any care for anything else besides short-term advantage, everyone, personally, being extremely keen to learn and practise any ^{831d} subject or activity that leads to this objective, and laughing at any others. This, we must insist, is one particular cause of a city's refusal to take this or any other noble and good pursuit seriously. Indeed, because of this insatiable desire for gold and silver, everyone is prepared to resort to any skill or device, noble or unseemly, provided it is going to make him rich. He will perform any act, holy or unholy, even an utterly disgraceful one, without scruple, as long as he is able to provide himself, like some wild beast, with total, unrestricted ^{831e} satisfaction in eating, drinking and lust, in endless variety.

^{831e}

Clinias: Correct.

Athenian: Well, this cause, the one I am speaking of, may be set down as one that prevents cities from properly practising military activities or any other noble pursuits, and turns people who are naturally well behaved into traders, merchants and out-and-out servants, while ^{832a} making pirates, thieves, temple robbers, thugs and tyrants of the courageous types, although much of the time they are not bad-natured but unfortunate.

832a

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: Unfortunate in the extreme. How else could I describe people who are compelled to go through life with a constant hunger in their own souls?

Clinias: Well, that's one cause. What's the second cause, stranger?

Athenian: It is good that you remind me.

832b

Clinias: Yes, according to you, one cause is the insatiable lifelong search which keeps people busy, and gets in the way of the proper practice of military exercises. So be it. Now tell us the second cause.

832c

Athenian: I expect you think that I am delaying and won't tell you because I am at a loss.

Clinias: No, but you do seem to us, out of a sort of hatred for the character you are describing, to be castigating him more than is required by the present argument.

Athenian: An excellent rebuke, strangers. It seems you want to hear what comes next.

Clinias: Speak on.

Athenian: I maintain that the causes lie in the 'non-constitutions' which have been mentioned so many times in the preceding arguments, the democratic, the oligarchic and the tyrannical. In truth, not one of these is a political system; indeed, they may all quite correctly be called 'states-of-faction'. None of them involves willing rule over willing subjects, but willing rule over the unwilling, always with some degree of force, and the ruler, out of fear of his subject, will never willingly allow him to become noble, wealthy, strong,

courageous or in ^{832d} any way military. Now these, more or less, are the two main causes of all evils, at least of the evils we are now considering. However, the political system for which we are now enacting laws has eliminated both. For it presumably allows the most free time and its citizens are free from one another, and under these laws, I believe, they would be least fond of wealth. Consequently, it is reasonable to expect that of all political systems, only the one arranged in this way would make allowance for the military education we have set out, which is also an amusement, as described appropriately in our account.

^{832d}

Clinias: Good.

Athenian: After all this, shouldn't we declare once and for all, regarding athletic contests in general, that those that are militarily useful should be pursued and prizes for victory should be awarded, while those that are not should be set aside? It is best to begin by stating which these are and by enacting laws. And we should first provide for contests in running and ^{832e} rapidity in general, shouldn't we?

^{832e}

Clinias: We should.

Athenian: Now, bodily agility in general of the feet or the hands is more useful than anything else for military purposes. In flight and in pursuit, fleetness of foot is required, while in a set fight at close quarters calling for endurance and strength, quick hands are needed.

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: But in the absence of weapons, neither of these has its full effect.

Clinias: No, how could they?

^{833a}

Athenian: So, at our competitions, the herald, as he does nowadays, shall first call the short distance runner, and he shall come in wearing his armour, and we shall award no prize to a competitor without armour. First then, the competitor who runs one stade in full armour shall enter, second comes the contestant who runs twice that distance, third is the one who runs the length of the horse track, fourth the chariot-course runner, and then fifth is the one in heavier armour whom we shall despatch, in the first instance, to run sixty stades to some temple of Ares and back again. We shall call him a hoplite, and he shall follow a smooth course, while his rival, an archer wearing full archer's gear, must run one hundred stades⁸⁷ ^{833b} through hills and varied countryside to a temple of Apollo and Artemis. And having set up the competitions, we shall wait until the contestants return and award the prizes to the victors in each event.

^{833b}

Clinias: Rightly so.

Athenian: Then, let us devise contests in these three classes – one for children, one for youths and one for men. And let's set the course distance for youths at two-thirds of the full length, ^{833c} and for children at half the length, whether they compete as archers or as hoplites. In the case of females, girls who have not yet attained womanhood are to run one stade, two stades, the horse track and the chariot course, without gear, on the course itself. From the age of thirteen, while awaiting marriage between the ages of eighteen and twenty, they may still be involved, but they must put on the proper gear when entering these races. So ^{833d} let these be the arrangements concerning running for men and women. As for events involving strength, instead of wrestling and the like, the 'heavy' contest of today, let's arrange fights in armour, one against one, two against two, up to a maximum of ten contending against ten. What must be

accepted and what may be done to win a victory, and the points awarded, should be decided based upon current practice in wrestling where the relevant officials regulate what constitutes good wrestling and what does not. So we, in like manner, should call upon experts in armour fighting and ask them to help us to make ^{833e} laws about who rightly deserves victory in these fights, what he must do or avoid, and, similarly, the rules for deciding the loser. Let these regulations also apply to females until they are married. For boxing in the pancration,⁸⁸ we should substitute general combat using missiles; fighting with bows, light shields, javelins and stones thrown by hand or with slings. For these too we must make regulations, awarding the honours of victory to the one who best conforms to the rules of these competitions.

^{834a}

Athenian: After these should be the regulation of horse-racing. But we don't have much use for horses, nor are there many of them, certainly not in Crete at any rate, and so their breeding and racing is inevitably taken less seriously. As for chariots, there is no one at all who keeps them, nor would anyone have any significant ambition in that direction. Consequently, ^{834b} to set up a competition of this sort, contrary to local custom, would not be an intelligent course of action, nor would it seem so. But if we were to institute prizes for horse-riding on colts, young horses and full-grown animals, we would be adapting the sport of horsemanship to the nature of the country. For these particular competitors, then, let there be competitive contests established by law, and let judgement both of the actual courses themselves, and of the competitors bearing arms, be entrusted jointly to the company commanders and cavalry commanders. For competitors who are unarmed it would not be right to set up compe- ^{834c} titions by law, either in this case of horsemanship, or for the athletes. For a Cretan there is some advantage in being a mounted archer or javelin-thrower, so let there be

sportive rivalry and competition in these activities too. Yet there is no merit in forcing women, by laws and regulations, to be involved in these contests. But if, due to their earlier education, a habit has developed whereby their nature accepts such involvement when they are children or young women, let them do so and let there be no criticism.

834d

Athenian: Well now, at this stage the subject of competition and instruction in gymnastics has been concluded, including our endeavours in relation to contests and day-to-day teaching. Similarly, too, in the case of music, most aspects have been dealt with, but the matter of rhapsodes and anything associated with them, and any choral competitions required at our festivals, shall be put in order once the months, days and years have been assigned to the gods and their associates, also determining whether the festivals should be held every two ^{834e} years or every four years, or whatever interval or manner the gods may suggest. On these occasions we should expect the music competitions to be held, in turn, as set down jointly by judges of the contests, the educator of the young, and the guardians of the law, at a meeting concerning these very matters where they act as lawgivers, determining when, by whom, and with whom the contests will be instituted in the case of all choruses and dances. The original lawgiver has frequently declared what each of these should be like with respect to ^{835a} their words, melody, and harmony combined with rhythm and dance. These secondary legislators should follow his lead, allocating the contests appropriately to each sacrifice at fitting times, thus providing the city with festivals to celebrate. Now, it is not difficult to recognise how to give a legal structure to these regulations and others like them. Nor indeed would changing them this way and that be greatly to the advantage or detriment of the city. But there is a matter that makes a difference, a significant difference, about which it is difficult to persuade

people. In fact, it is really a task for a god, ^{835b} if it were somehow possible for guidance to come directly from such a source. But, for now, what is needed is probably some courageous person who, valuing frankness above all else, will say what he believes to be best for the city and its citizens, someone who, surrounded by corrupted souls, prescribes what is appropriate and becoming to the constitution, speaking in opposition to the most powerful desires of all, with no one else to help as he stands alone, by reason alone.

^{835c}

Clinias: What point are you making now, stranger? We don't understand you so far.

Athenian: That is not unexpected. In that case, I will try to explain myself to you more clearly. Indeed, when my argument arrived at the topic of education, I pictured young men and women consorting with one another in a friendly manner, and, not unexpectedly, I became fearful as I considered how one is to manage a city like this in which young men and ^{835d} women, well reared, are exempt from the hard work which does so much to curb the passions, and for whom sacrifices, festivals and choruses are their lifelong concern. In a city like this, how precisely will the young refrain from those desires that so often plunge so many into ruin, desires from which reason, in an effort to become law, directs them to refrain? Now, if our previous regulations as enacted were to curtail most of these desires, that would not be surprising. Indeed, the prohibition on becoming excessively wealthy is ^{835e} of considerable benefit in promoting sound-mindedness, and their entire education includes regulations adapted for similar purposes. What's more, the eye of the officials, having been trained to look nowhere else and to be constantly vigilant towards the young people themselves, brings an element of measure to their desires in general, insofar as this is humanly possible. However, when it

comes to the loves of children of either sex, or of men for women or women for men, which have had all sorts of consequences for individuals and for entire ^{836a} cities, how may he guard against this and what remedy is to be found to avoid such a danger in each of these cases? This question, Clinias, is not at all easy to answer. And, indeed, Crete in general, and Sparta too, have given us reasonable assistance in framing laws that are unusual compared to most, but when it comes to these loves, I have to say, just between ourselves, that the position is the exact opposite. What if someone, following the natural ^{836b} order, should institute the law previous to that of your lawmaker, Laius,⁸⁹ and maintain that it is not right for males to consort with males, old or young, in the same way as they have intercourse with females? In the process, he might cite the natural habits of animals and point out that in such situations males do not have contact with males because this is contrary to nature, and he would then perhaps have a persuasive argument even though this ^{836c} does not conform to the practices of your cities. What is more, the matter which, according to us, demands the utmost vigilance of the lawgiver, does not fit in well with these practices of yours. For we are constantly enquiring as to which enactments are conducive to excellence and which are not.

^{836d}

Athenian: So, come on then, suppose we were to agree that this practice is noble and not at all disgraceful, and were now to legislate accordingly. What consequence would follow in terms of excellence? Will it engender the quality of courage in the soul of the one who is seduced, or develop some form of sound-mindedness in the soul of the seducer? Surely no one will ever believe this. Quite the contrary; everyone will censure the softness of a person ^{836e} who yields to pleasures and is incapable of mastering them, and won't they also rebuke the man who imitates a woman for his very resemblance thereto? This being

the case, who on earth will ever legislate for such a practice? Hardly anyone, not if they have any notion of what true law is. So how are we to maintain that this is all true? If anyone is to think aright ^{837a} about these matters, he will need to discern the nature of friendship, of desire too, and of what is referred to as love. For there are these two, and from both, another third form arises, but a single name encompasses the three and this gives rise to all sorts of perplexity and obscurity.

^{837a}

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: We refer, as you know, to the friendship of like for like and of equal for equal in respect of excellence, and indeed of the needy for the wealthy, despite being opposite in kind. And whenever either friendship becomes intense, we call it love.

^{837b}

Clinias: And rightly so.

Athenian: Well, the affection between opposites is fierce and wild, and among ourselves it is seldom mutual, while affection between like for like is gentle, mutual and lifelong. When there is a mixture of these two, firstly, it is not easy to appropriate what precisely someone who has this third love wants for himself, and secondly, he is perplexed as he is dragged in opposite directions by one or the other, one encouraging him to avail himself of the delight, ^{837c} the other forbidding him. For one person loves the body, and being hungry to pluck the ripe fruit of its delights, he encourages himself to have his fill without showing the least regard for the soul of the beloved or its condition. The other man, however, regarding desire of the body as a diversion, contemplates rather than loves; he really desires soul with soul, and regards the sating of body by body as wantonness. Respecting and revering sound-mindedness, courage, magnanimity and wisdom, he would wish to live in

constant ^{837d} purity with his pure beloved. The kind of love which is a mixture of both is the one we have just described as the third love. Now, since there are three of them, should the law prohibit all of them and prevent their occurrence among us, or is it obvious that the one that loves excellence and wants the young person to be as excellent as possible is what we would like to have in our city, while prohibiting the other two if this were possible? What is our position here, my dear Megillus?

^{837e}

Megillus: I say, stranger, that you have just spoken very well in every respect on these matters.

Athenian: It seems, my friend, as indeed I suspected, that I meet with your approval. The law among yourselves in Sparta, and what it thinks about such matters, is something I don't need to investigate, I need only accept your approval of my argument. After this, on another occasion, I shall try charming Clinias into agreeing with me. What you both concede to me should be left at that, and we should return, by all means, to dealing with the laws.

Megillus: Quite correct.

^{838a}

Athenian: I have a device ready to hand for establishing this law, and although it is straightforward, it is also, in a way, as difficult as could be.

Megillus: What are you referring to?

Athenian: We know indeed that even nowadays most people, however lawless they are, are well ^{838b} and truly prevented, without any resistance and with complete consent, from having intercourse with beautiful people.

^{838b}

Megillus: On what occasions?

Athenian: When they have brothers or sisters who are beautiful. Also, in the case of a son or daughter, the same law, although it is unwritten, is quite enough to guard against anyone lying with them either openly or in secret, or wanting to touch them in this way. No, the desire for this intercourse does not even occur to them at all.

Megillus: That's true.

Athenian: Doesn't one little saying extinguish all such pleasures?

838c

Megillus: What saying do you mean?

Athenian: The saying that these practices are not at all holy, are detested by God, and are the most disgraceful of all disgraceful deeds. The explanation for this is that no one speaks differently from anyone else about these matters. Rather, each of us, as soon as we are born, hears this spoken of in comic utterances, or frequently in serious tragedy when Oedipus or Thyestes appears,⁹⁰ or a Macareus having intercourse in secret with his sister, all of whom are seen readily inflicting death upon themselves as the penalty for their misdeeds when they come to light.

Megillus: You're quite right in saying this much anyway, that popular opinion possesses a wondrous power once no one at all attempts to breathe a word that does not accord with the law.

838d

Athenian: Isn't it right, then, as I said just now, that it is easy enough for a lawgiver who wishes to restrain a desire that utterly enslaves people at least to recognise how he should go about it? By making this saying sacred in the eyes of everyone, bond or free, children and women, and the entire city on the same basis, he will thus be ensuring that this law is firmly established.

Megillus: Very well, but how it will ever be possible to arrange that everyone will be willing to say this sort of thing...

838e

Athenian: A good interjection. Indeed, this is what I was saying, that in relation to this law I might have a device for ensuring the natural use of reproductive intercourse; the male refraining from the male, thus avoiding the deliberate annihilation of the human race by sowing seed into rocks and stones where it will never take root and adopt its own fruitful nature; refraining also from any female field in which you would not want the sown seed to spring up. This law, then, having become permanent and holding sway in the same way that the law about intercourse of parents with their children prevails nowadays, would indeed confer countless benefits if it were also to prevail, as is only right, in the other cases too.

839a

Athenian: Firstly, it is in accord with nature and it brings about restraint of the raging madness of love, of all sorts of debauchery, of any excesses in drinking and eating, and, indeed, it makes men friendly and affectionate towards their own wedded wives. There would also be countless other benefits if it were possible for someone to have this law enforced. But perhaps some intense young man, his seed overflowing, might be close by and hear us proposing our law, and he might ridicule it as a stupid regulation that is impossible to implement, and fill the air with his declamations. This is what I had in mind when I made the statement that I had a particular device for ensuring that this law is permanently established, ^{839b} in a way the easiest device of all, but in a way, extremely difficult. In fact, it is easy enough to appreciate that this is possible and how it is possible, for according to us, once this law has been made sacred enough, every soul will become subject to it. This will lead to a fear ^{839c} of the established laws, and total obedience to them. But nowadays things have come to such a pass that even with this law in place,

it seems that the desired outcome might not come about. It is just like the situation with the practice of common meals, where the possibility of implementing this in the daily life of the entire city is greeted with disbelief. And ^{839d} even though it is an actual practice among yourselves, nevertheless, even in your own cities, the extension of this practice so as to include women is regarded as contrary to nature. And so, it was because of the strength of this disbelief that I said that both these practices are extremely difficult to establish permanently as law.

^{839d}

Megillus: And you were right to say so.

Athenian: So, would you like me to try to formulate some argument possessing some degree of certainty to show that this can actually happen and is not beyond human capacity?

Clinias: Of course.

^{839e}

Athenian: Tell me, then, in which of these cases would someone exercise sexual restraint more easily and be willing to do as directed in these matters, with due measure – when his body is in good condition and not out of training, or when it is run down?

Clinias: When it is not out of training, this is much easier.

^{840a}

Athenian: Yes, and we all know what is said about Iccus of Tarentum because of his involvement in the contests at Olympia and elsewhere.⁹¹ Due to his sheer ambition in these competitions, his professionalism, and the courage combined with sound-mindedness he possessed in his soul, they say he never touched a woman, or, indeed, a boy either, while his training was at its peak. And, indeed, the same story is also told of Crison and Astylus and Diopompus and very many others. And yet, Clinias, these people had received a far inferior

education in ^{840b} soul than your citizens and mine, while their bodies were much more vigorous.

^{840b}

Clinias: You're right in saying so. Yes, it has been confidently reported by men of old that this was indeed what actually happened in the case of these athletes.

Athenian: Well then, are these athletes to refrain from what most people refer to as a blissful activity, all for the sake of victory in the ring or on the track and such like, while our young folk refuse to tolerate restraint for the sake of a much more sublime victory? This is a victory ^{840c} whose glory we shall praise as we speak to them from their very childhood, in the hope of charming them, using stories, speeches and songs.

^{840c}

Clinias: What victory?

Athenian: The victory over pleasures, which, if they win it, ensures a happy life, we'll say, whereas if they are defeated, the outcome is the exact opposite. And besides this, won't a foreboding at the out and out unholiness of this activity be capable of ensuring this victory for them, a victory which has been won by others who are worse people than these citizens of ours?

Clinias: Quite likely.

^{840d}

Athenian: Well, this is our predicament in relation to this particular regulation: we have been cast into perplexity by the evil ways of the majority of people. So I maintain that our regulation on these particular matters should simply proceed by stating that our citizens ought not to be worse creatures than birds and any other animals that flock together on a large scale. Until the time for reproduction arrives, they live unwed, as pure, chaste virgins, and when they reach the appropriate

age they come together in pairs, as they prefer, male with female, ^{840e} female with male, and live out their lives in holiness and justice, constant and true to their first ties of affection. Surely our citizens should be superior to animals. But what if, instead, they are corrupted by the vast majority of Greeks and non-Greeks in general, seeing and hearing of the enormous power of the so-called 'irregular love' among these people, and consequently prove unable to win this sublime victory? Then the guardians of the law must become lawgivers and devise a second law for them.

^{841a}

Clinias: What law would you advise them to implement if the one we are now implementing evades them?

Athenian: The one that comes after this one is obviously second, Clinias.

Clinias: Which do you mean?

Athenian: There was a way of making the power of these pleasures largely ineffective by diverting their influx and sustenance elsewhere through physical work. This would also happen if there were less shamelessness involved in recourse to sexual activity, since because of the shame, resort to this would be more sparing and, being used less frequently, the strength of ^{841b} its tyranny would be reduced. Let them accept then that discretion in such activity is something noble, endorsed by custom and unwritten law, while lack of discretion is shameful. But they need not refrain from the activity completely. In this way, we would have a second best standard of what's shameful or noble, established by this law, and a second-best standard of rightness too, and the particular kind of people whose natures have been corrupted, whom we describe as inferior to themselves, would be restrained by a threefold barrier and prevented from transgressing the law.

^{841b}

Clinias: What are the three?

841c

Athenian: Reverence for God, accompanied by love of honour and the birth of a desire for the beautiful qualities of the soul rather than those of the physical bodies. What we are now saying may well be a sort of combination of fable and prayer, and yet if this were to happen it would be the very best thing that could happen in any city. But perhaps, God willing, we might enforce one or the other of two regulations concerning sexual relations. One would be that no noble freeborn person should dare to touch any except his own wedded wife, or sow unconsecrated and illegitimate seed with concubines, or sow unproductive seed with 841d males, in contravention of nature. Alternatively, we could completely ban sexual activity with males, and in the case of women, if anyone consorts with any woman save those brought into his house and consecrated by divine marriage rites, whether he buys her or acquires her in any other way, and he is found out by any man or woman, we would probably be right in enacting by law that he be deprived of his rights and honours as a citizen of the city because he is, in truth, an alien. So this law then, whether we refer to it as one law or as two, should apply to sexual relations and all matters concerning love, and what practices 841e are right and what practices are not right, in our interaction with one another by reason of such desires as these.

841e

Megillus: Well, stranger, for my own part I would accept this law without reservation, but Clinias should declare for himself what precisely his views on these matters are.

Clinias: That's what I'll do, Megillus, whenever I think the occasion is right. For now, let's allow the stranger to proceed further with his laws.

Megillus: Right.

842a

Athenian: Very well then, our proceedings have now reached the point at which common meals have been more or less established. Elsewhere, according to us, this would be difficult, but in Crete no one suggests doing anything differently. As for the manner in which they are arranged and whether the system here or the system in Sparta is better, or whether there is some third system that is better than both, this would not, I think, be difficult to ascertain, but there would be no great advantage in doing so. In fact, we have now made these arrangements in a satisfactory manner.

842b

Athenian: The next issue is provision for these common meals in a manner suited to them. In 842c the case of cities, there would be a huge variety of provisions from lots of different places, at least twice as many sources as these cities of ours. For most Greek cities get their food supply from the land and from the sea, while these cities of ours get it from the land alone. This makes things easy for the lawgiver, for the number of laws required would be less than half, much less, and besides, they would be more suited to a free people. Our lawgiver, being largely quit of merchant shipping, trading, retailing, inn-keeping, compound interest and countless other requirements of that sort, will then pass laws for farmers, herdsmen, beekeepers, and for those who supervise such matters and are responsible for the equipment.

842d

Athenian: He has already enacted laws dealing with the most important issues: marriage, the birth and upbringing of children, education, and the appointment of officials in the city. He now needs to turn his attention to legislating in relation to food and the people who collaborate in producing this.

842e

Athenian: Firstly, then, let there be laws that go by the name of 'agricultural'. The first law, the law of 'Zeus of the boundary', may be stated as follows. No one is to move a land boundary marker, either of a neighbour who is a fellow citizen, or when he owns land bordering a foreign frontier and his neighbour is a foreigner. He must realise that, in doing ^{843a} so, he is, in truth, moving the immovable.⁹² And everyone must prefer to attempt the removal of some enormous rock that isn't a boundary marker rather than the tiny stone, consecrated to the gods, that marks off the land of a friend or the land of a foe. For in one case, Zeus, god of the clan, is witness, and in the other case, Zeus, god of strangers, is witness, and when these are aroused the most bitter conflicts follow. Now, whoever obeys the law shall not suffer any of its penalties, while those who disregard it are to be subject to a twofold ^{843b} retribution, first and foremost from the gods, and secondly from the law. For no one is deliberately to move the boundary markers of his neighbour's land, and whoever does so is to be reported to the land-owners by anyone who wishes, and they in turn should take him to court. If someone is convicted of such a crime, since the offender is making a redistribution of land by stealth or by force, let the court decide what penalty the guilty party must suffer, or the compensation he should pay.

^{843c}

Athenian: Furthermore, lots of minor grievances between neighbours, by their very frequency, give rise to a significant accumulation of ill-feeling, and turn neighbourly relations into something difficult and extremely bitter. Therefore, a neighbour must be extremely careful to do nothing offensive to a neighbour, in general, and must always be particularly careful not to encroach on his land at all. For it is not difficult to do harm – anyone can do so – but not everyone can confer a benefit. Whoever encroaches upon the land of his neighbour, disregarding the boundary markers, is to make good any

damage, and, what's more, to cure ^{843d} him of his shamelessness and unworthy behaviour, he is to pay double the damages to the victim in addition. In all cases of this sort, let the rural commissioners act as inspectors, judges and assessors. In major cases, as stated previously, the entire command structure of the district is to act, while in lesser cases the guard commanders may do so.

^{843e}

Athenian: If someone's cattle graze on another's land, these officials shall decide the case and the penalty once they have inspected the damage. And if anyone exploits the susceptibility of bees and appropriates a hive by making rattling noises to attract them to his own property, he is to pay damages. And if he should light a fire and is not careful about his neighbour's materials, he is to pay a fine as assessed by the officials. He is also to be fined if, while planting trees, he plants them too close to his neighbour's property. These are issues that lots of lawgivers have dealt with quite adequately, and we should simply make use of their ^{844a} laws and not expect the important person who is putting our city in order to legislate for the numerous trivial matters which any random lawgiver could deal with.

^{844b}

Athenian: Since time-tested laws are already in place for farmers concerning water supply, we need not draw upon these for our argument. Rather, anyone who wants to bring water to his own holding from the communal sources may bring the water provided he does not intercept the exposed well of any private individual and he avoids any houses, temples and tombs and does no damage beyond what's required for the channelling. In areas where the land is naturally arid and fails to retain the heaven-sent waters and there is a shortage of necessary drinking water, the person should dig on his own land until he reaches the clay subsoil, and if he does not

encounter any water at all at that depth, he is to be supplied by his neighbours with enough drinking water to meet the needs of every member of his household.

844c

Athenian: If the scarcity also extends to his neighbours, he is to make arrangements for a water supply with the rural commissioners, receiving this on a daily basis, and share his neighbours' water in this way. And when the rains from heaven come, if someone does damage to the farm or the adjoining house that lies below his own by blocking the outflow of water, or, conversely, the person above damages the holding below by carelessly discharging the flow, and the parties are unwilling to accommodate one another, either may go to the city commissioners, in one case, or the rural commissioners, in the other, for a direction as to what they should do. Anyone who does not abide by such a direction is to be penalised for his grudging and unco-operative spirit, and on conviction is to pay double the damage to the injured party for his refusal to obey the officials.

844d

Athenian: In the case of the fruit harvest, the generally accepted rule should be as follows. Two gifts are bestowed upon us by the grace of this goddess, one being the bounty of Dionysus that none can store, the other naturally produced for storage. So, let the following law be enacted concerning the fruit harvest. Whoever tastes the coarse fruit, whether grapes or figs, before the season of the vintage comes with the rising of Arcturus,⁹³ either from his own land or from another's, is to pay fifty drachmas, sacred to Dionysus, if he plucks it from his own property, a mina if plucked from his neighbour's land, and two thirds of a ^{844e} mina if it was taken from elsewhere. Whoever wants to harvest what nowadays are called special grapes or special figs may gather them as and when he wishes if he takes them from his own land. But if he takes them from someone

else's land without permission, he is to be fined for each offence in accordance with the law which declares that you don't disturb what you have not set down. But if a slave touches such fruit without the permission of the landowner, he is to be whipped, receiving one stroke for each grape on the bunch or for every fig taken. A resident alien who has bought a crop of special fruit may harvest it if he so wishes. A visiting foreigner who wants fruit to eat as he travels the roads may, along with one attendant, avail of special fruit if he wishes, without payment, as our gift to our ^{845a} guest. As for the so-called coarse fruit and the like, the law should prohibit the visitor from sharing in these. And if anyone, master or slave, takes them unknowingly, the slave is to be punished by being beaten, while the free man is to be told off and instructed to avail of the other fruit that is not suitable for being stored to make raisins, wine or dried figs. Let there be no disgrace in taking apples, pears or pomegranates, or the like, secretly, but if anyone under thirty is caught in the act, let him get a beating, avoiding serious injury, as a deterrent, and let there be no legal redress available to a free man for such an assault. Let a foreigner ^{845b} be allowed to partake of this sort of fruit in just the same way as the grapes and figs, and if any older person avails of them, eating them on the spot and taking nothing away, let him have his share of all fruit of this sort, just like the foreigner. But if he disregards this law, ^{845c} he runs the risk of being disqualified from every public distinction when the time comes, if such behaviour is brought to the attention of the acting judges.

^{845d}

Athenian: Water, more so than anything else, is what sustains garden produce, but it is easily spoiled. For neither earth nor sun nor winds, which co-operate with water in nourishing the growing plants, are at all easy to spoil by poisons, diversion or theft. However, in the case of the water, it is possible for everything of that sort to happen, and so the protection of the

law is needed. So, let there be the following law about this. If anyone deliberately spoils another's water supply, in a spring or in a pond, with poisons, by digging trenches or by theft, the injured party is to take the case before the city commissioners, detailing the extent ^{845e} of the damage. If someone is found guilty of doing such damage using poisons, in addition to any fine he is also to purify the springs or water reservoir in whatever manner the legal interpreters prescribe for the conduct of the purification in any particular case, or on any particular occasion.

^{846a}

Athenian: When gathering in the season's harvest, it shall be open to anyone to convey his own produce through any place he wishes, provided he does no damage, or the profit he himself gains from the route is three times the damage done to his neighbour's property. In these cases, the officials are to act as assessors, and also in all other cases where someone maliciously harms the person or property of another by force or by stealth, by the way he uses his own possessions. All such cases are to be reported to the officials for award of compensation where the damage is less than three minae. If anyone makes a claim against another ^{846b} for a greater sum, he is to pursue the case before the public courts to secure redress from the wrongdoer. If any official is judged to have decided a penalty based upon an unjust opinion, he is to be liable to pay double damages to the injured party. And, indeed, anyone who wishes may challenge the unjust decisions of any officials before the public courts.

^{846c}

Athenian: Governing the conduct of the legal actions, there are countless minor regulations dealing with the statements of grievance, the summonses, the serving of the summons, and whether its service requires two witnesses or some other number, and so on and so forth. These matters do require legislation, but they are unworthy of a senior lawmaker. The

junior lawgivers then are to legislate for these matters, imitating the previous enactments, the minor imitating the major, having had practical experience of the need for their use, until they are all arranged in an adequate manner. Then, having fixed them permanently, they should live by them, since at that stage the measure is right.

846d

Athenian: For skilled workers in general we should proceed as follows. Firstly, no native citizen is to be numbered among those who labour at the professions of skilled workers, nor may the servant of a citizen do so either. For a citizen already has a sufficient profession, one that demands a lot of practice and a great deal of learning, in maintaining and preserving the good order of the city, and this needs to be a full-time occupation. For among us humans ^{846e} there is scarcely anyone who is naturally up to the task of working at two occupations or professions in a comprehensive manner. Nor indeed can we practise one profession ourselves while supervising someone else who is practising another. So, in our city, the guiding principle from the very outset should be that no one is to work as a smith and, at the same time, as a carpenter, nor indeed while working as a carpenter is he to supervise someone working as a smith rather than his own profession. It is no excuse to say that by supervising ^{847a} lots of subordinates who work on his behalf, he naturally supervises them better because his income from their work is greater than the income from his own profession. Rather, each skilled worker in the city is to have one profession, and from this he is also to earn his living. The rural commissioners then are to exert themselves in maintaining this law, and if any native person is inclined towards any profession to the neglect of the concern for excel- ^{847b} lence, they shall punish him with censure and loss of privileges until they return him to his own proper course. If any foreigner pursues two professions, they shall punish him with bonds, financial

penalties and expulsion from the city, thus compelling him to be one person rather than many. Cases involving payments to workers or the acceptance of their work, or where someone does an injustice to them or they wrong someone else, are to be decided by the rural commissioners up to a value of fifty drachmas, but if the amount involved is greater than this, the public courts are to judge the case according to the law.

847c

Athenian: No duties are to be paid in our city by anyone either on exported or imported goods. No one is to import frankincense or any other foreign produce of that sort relating to sacrifices to the gods, or purple or any coloured dyes not produced in the country, or anything associated with any other profession that requires imported goods but serves no necessary purpose. Nor indeed should any goods that are needed in the country be exported; they should remain. The overseers and supervisors of all these matters are to consist of the twelve guardians of the law who are left after the five senior members are exempted.

847d

Athenian: As for weaponry and all military equipment, there may be a need to import a particular skill, plant material, metal, rope, or animals, for such a purpose. If so, the cavalry commanders and generals are to be given responsibility for the imports and exports, the city itself being the buyer and seller, and the guardians of the law are to institute appropriate and adequate laws about these matters. No one in our country as a whole, or in our city, is to trade for financial gain, either in this or in anything else.

847e

Athenian: In the case of the food supply and its distribution, it seems that if a good system, coming close to that set out in the laws of Crete, were to be implemented, that would be quite suitable. Everyone should divide the total production of the

territory into twelve parts, which is how it is to be consumed. Each twelfth part of wheat, for instance, or barley, are allocations to which all the other allocations of the crops should conform, including any animals that are for sale in any district. These parts are to be divided into three, proportionately, one part for free-born citizens, one for their attendants, and the third for skilled workers and for foreigners in general, including communities of resident aliens who are in need of ^{848a} sustenance, or people who have come in for a time to do business with the city or some private citizens. Of all the basic necessities that have been allocated, this third portion is the only one that may be placed on sale compulsorily. There is to be no compulsion to sell any part of the other two divisions. Now, what would be the correct way to allocate these? In the first place it is obvious that in a way we are allocating them equally, and in a way unequally.

^{848a}

Clinias: What do you mean?

Athenian: The earth will, I presume, inevitably produce each of these portions in varying quality, some being better than others.

Clinias: Of course.

^{848b}

Athenian: In this regard, none of the three subdivisions, once allocated, is to involve any advantage, neither the one given to the masters nor to their slaves, nor indeed the one that belongs to the foreigners. Rather, the distribution shall ensure the same equality of likeness for everyone. Each of the citizens, having taken the two portions, is to be responsible for its distribution to slaves and to free-born, distributing as much as he wishes of whatever quality he wishes. The surplus from these should be distributed according to the following measures and numbers. It is to be distributed by counting up the total number of

animals that need to be sustained from the land.

848c

Athenian: What is needed next are individual houses for the inhabitants, suitably arranged, and the arrangement best suited to such purposes is as follows. There should be twelve villages, one in the centre of each of the twelve regions. And in each village we should first set aside 848d temples and a marketplace for the gods and their associated divinities. And if there are any local divinities belonging to the Magnetes, or shrines of other ancient divinities whose memory is still preserved, they are to be granted the same ancient honours that those people gave them. And in every one of the twelve districts, temples are to be founded to Hestia, Zeus, Athena or whatever other god happens to be the patron of the region. To begin with, there 848e are to be dwellings around these temples, wherever the ground is highest, as the most secure lodging possible for the guards. All the rest of the territory is to be provided with skilled workers who are to be divided into thirteen groups. One of these will take up residence in the city itself, and this group shall in turn be divided into twelve parts corresponding to the twelve divisions of the entire city, dwelling round about on the outskirts, while in each village the kinds of workers that will be useful to the farmers are to be given residence there. The supervisors of all these arrangements are to be the people in charge of the rural commissioners. They are to decide the number and type of workers each region needs, and where they should live so that they will be the least trouble and of maximum benefit to the 849a farmers. And in the city, in like manner, the board in charge of the city commissioners should have and retain the supervision of the workers.

849b

Athenian: The market commissioners are of course to look after everything to do with the market. Their second task, after their oversight of the temples adjacent to the market in case anyone

does anything wrong, is to oversee the way people conduct their business, watching out for proper and improper behaviour, punishing anyone who needs to be punished. They shall first of all see to it that when the city folk are required to sell goods to foreigners, the sale is conducted according to the law in every case. The law for each item will be that on the first of the month the portion of the goods that are to be sold to the foreigners should be brought out by the agents – that is, the foreigners or slaves who have been given this task by the city folk. Beginning with corn, the foreigner is to purchase at the first market a month's supply of corn and whatever is associated with it. On the tenth ^{849c} of the month, the sale and purchase of liquid goods is to be conducted, enough to last for the entire month. Every third month, on the twentieth day, let there be a sale of any livestock that need to be bought or sold to meet the needs of those involved. Let there also be a sale by farmers of any goods or materials such as hides, clothing items in general, woven materials, felt, and anything else of that sort, items that foreigners are required to purchase from other people.

^{849d}

Athenian: As for trading in these goods, barley or wheat flour, or other foodstuffs in general, no one is to sell these to citizens or their slaves, nor may anyone buy these from them. However, in the markets of the foreigners, a foreigner, dealing in wine and corn, may sell to the skilled workers and their slaves, which most people call trading. Butchers too may cut up animals and distribute the meat among foreigners, skilled workers and their attendants. Any wood for burning may be bought in bulk on any day by a foreigner, as he wishes, from the agent in the localities, and he may sell it on himself to other foreigners as much as he wishes, whenever he wishes.

^{849e}

Athenian: The other goods or products that people need are to be sold in the public market, being brought to the specific location where the rural commissioners, assisted by the city commissioners, mark out suitable sites, defining the positions of the stalls. Here, goods are exchanged for money and money for goods, and no one may forgo his part of the transaction. And if anyone does forgo his part and thus give credit, he must accept his fate whether he is repaid or not, because no legal redress is available for a contract in such matters. If ^{850a} the extent or value of the purchase or sale contravenes the law that sets upper and lower limits beyond which neither transaction may go, the excess shall be recorded immediately by the guardians of the law in the case of excess, or the transaction shall be cancelled in the opposite case.

^{850b}

Athenian: The same rules about the recording of excess wealth are also to apply to resident aliens. Anyone who wishes may become a resident alien on specified terms, since residency is open to any foreigner who wishes to reside here and is able to do so provided he has a skill and dwells here no more than twenty years from his date of registration. All we require is his good behaviour, so he need pay no aliens' tax, nor indeed any duty on purchases or sales, and on completion of his permitted stay he may depart taking his wealth with him. And if during this time with us he acquires a good reputation because of some significant service to the city, and he believes he can convince the Council and the Assembly either that he deserves an official postponement of his departure, or even lifelong permanent residency, let him come forward and persuade the city, and whatever he persuades them of ^{850c} shall be his in full. For children of resident aliens who are skilled workers and have reached fifteen years of age, their period of official residency shall begin after they turn fifteen. When one of them has remained for twenty years on the specified terms, he may go

wherever he likes. If he wishes to remain, he may do so, subject to the same procedure for convincing the state. On departure, he is to ensure that any official records, previously recorded by the officials, are erased.

BOOK IX

853a

Athenian: The next topics in our systematisation of the laws would naturally be the legal procedures associated with all the activities referred to previously. Although some of the matters that give rise to legal proceedings have been dealt with, in the case of farming and related activities the most significant issues have not yet been dealt with. So, explaining this in 853b detail, stating what offence requires what punishment and before what courts it should be tried, these are the issues that should be dealt with next.

853b

Clinias: And rightly so.

Athenian: Now, there is an element of disgrace in actually legislating, as we are proposing to do on all these issues, in a city of this sort, which, according to us is well managed and possessed of all the right conditions for the cultivation of excellence. The very assumption that some citizens might grow up in a city like ours, sharing in the depravities of other cities in their most extreme forms – so that we need to pass laws in anticipation as a deterrent in 853c case such people arise, and that we have to put laws in place for them, to warn and punish them as if they were going to exist – this, as I said, involves an element of disgrace. But we are not now legislating like the lawgivers of ancient times, who, as we are told, passed laws for heroes and children of the gods, they themselves being descended from gods, imposing 853d laws on others of similar stock. We, rather, are humans, setting laws for those who are

sprung from human stock. So we may be forgiven for being afraid lest any of our citizens prove to have a sort of hard shell, and to be so tough by nature as to be incapable of softening. They could be just like hard-shelled seeds in the heat of the fire, and might prove incapable of softening down when exposed to our laws, strong and all as they are. It is, then, for the sad sake of these people that I shall begin dealing with the plundering of temples, in case anyone has the audacity to do such a deed. Now we would never wish, nor indeed would we expect in the least, that any citizen who has been properly brought up would ever be infected by this disease. But slaves, foreigners, and the slaves of foreigners might often turn their hands to such misdeeds. So, it is mainly for their sake, but ^{854a} also out of a wariness of the overall weakness of human nature, that I shall state this law dealing with the plundering of temples, and all the other diseases of this sort that are difficult or impossible to cure. And, on the principle agreed upon previously, we should include preambles to all such laws, keeping them as brief as possible. We might address that person with words of reason and of encouragement, the person whom evil desire exhorts on a daily ^{854b} basis and awakens at night, leading him on to plunder temples. We might say, "Dearest, it is no human badness, or divine badness either, that sets in train this inclination to go out and plunder temples. It is a madness that springs up in people because of ancient injustices that have not been cleansed, and it is still running its accursed course. This you must guard against with all your strength. Listen to the caution you must exercise. Whenever any ^{854c} notions of this sort assail you, turn to the sacrifices that banish the evil, go as a supplicant to the temples of the gods who avert evils, seek the company of those among you who are reputed to be good and learn from them, and say this yourself, that everyone should honour what is noble and what is just, and flee headlong from bad company. And if, by such a course, the disease abates, well and good. And if not, then

look to death as the better option and take your leave of this life.”

854d

Athenian: These are the preambles we are to intone to those who are intent upon all these unholy deeds that undermine our city. For those who are already convinced, the law may remain unspoken. But for those who are not convinced, the law, besides the preamble, must proclaim loudly that whoever is caught plundering a temple, be he a slave or a foreigner, shall have the misfortune written onto his forehead and his hands, and he shall suffer as many lashes of the whip as the judges deem fit, and he is to be cast out beyond the borders of our country, naked. For perhaps having suffered this punishment, he might become a better, more sound-minded person. Indeed, no penalty imposed by law aims to do any harm. In general, it brings about one of two outcomes: it either makes the person who receives the punishment a better person or, failing that, a less degenerate one.

854e

Athenian: But if some citizen ever exhibits such behaviour by perpetrating enormous, unspeakable injustices against the gods, his parents or the city, the judges, reckoning that he has not refrained from the most extreme evils in spite of the education and upbringing he has been receiving from his earliest years, are to regard this fellow as already incurable. The penalty in this case is death, the least of evils, serving as an example for the benefit of others, and he is to be buried anonymously beyond the borders of our country.

855a

Athenian: His children and family, if they shun the ways of the father, are to be famous, spoken of with honour as people who have done well and acted courageously in fleeing from evil to good. It would not be appropriate that the property of any such person be forfeited to the state in any city in which the

property allocations must always be equal and of the same number. When someone has done an injustice that seems to deserve a financial penalty, the fine may properly be paid only when there is a surplus over and above what is needed to maintain the holding. The fine may not exceed this surplus. In these cases, the guardians of the law are to look at the details in the registers, and consistently convey the exact information to the judges so that none of the holdings ever falls out of use through a deficiency of funds.

855b

Athenian: If it is decided that someone deserves a fine of more than this, and it turns out that none of his friends is willing to act as surety by getting together to pay the fine and secure his freedom, he is to be punished with prolonged imprisonment, public disgrace and degrading treatment. No one is ever to lose his citizen's rights completely for any transgressions, not even if he flees the country. Rather, the penalty should be death, imprisonment, beating, or some degrading situations or positions, or placement before temples on the country's borders, or fines subject to the strictures we described earlier.

855c

Athenian: In the case of the death penalty, the guardians of the law are to be the judges, along with a court, selected on merit from the officials who held office in the previous year. The bringing of the case, the summons and the like, and how the case is to be conducted, should be dealt with by the junior lawgivers, while it should be our job to legislate for the voting procedure. The vote is to be conducted openly, and before this happens our judges are to take their seats in close formation in order of seniority, face to face with the defendant and the accuser.

855d

Athenian: All citizens who have the time shall attend and pay close attention to such cases. The accuser is to speak first, the

defendant second, each making a single speech. After these speeches, the most senior judge shall present his examination of the case, conducting a comprehensive review of what was said in the speeches. After the eldest, they are all, in ^{855e} turn, to go through in detail whatever they found lacking or mistaken in any way in the speeches of either side. Any judge who finds nothing lacking should hand over his review time to someone else.

^{856a}

Athenian: Whatever seems relevant in what has been said is to have a seal affixed thereto, the signatures of all the judges are to be attached, and the document is to be placed on the altar of Hestia. They are to meet again the next day in the same place, review the case in the same way, and sign the statements once more. Having done this three times, giving due consideration to the evidence and the witnesses, each judge is to cast a sacred vote, swearing before the altar of Hestia to give just and true judgement as best they can, thus bringing a case like this to a close.

^{856b}

Athenian: After cases concerning the gods come those dealing with the subversion of the constitution. Whoever attempts to enslave the laws by placing them under human control or making the city subject to some party, and does all this by force and stirs up faction, this person indeed should be thought of as the worst enemy of all to the entire city. And anyone holding any of the most important positions of power in the city who does not take part in ^{856c} such machinations, yet fails to notice all this, or who notices it and, out of cowardice, fails to stand up for his own fatherland, is the sort of citizen who should be regarded as second in the scale of badness. Any man who is worth anything must inform the officials by bringing the plotter to court on a charge of changing the constitution by force and of breaking the law. The judges in these cases are to be the same as

for the temple plunderers, and the entire case is to be conducted in the very same way, and their vote may impose the death penalty by majority verdict. But to be brief, in no case is the disgrace or punishment of the ^{856d} father to fall upon the children except where someone's father, grandfather and great-grandfather have all, in turn, incurred the death penalty. The city is to send these children back to their own fatherland and city, along with their personal property, except for the wealth required to equip the holding fully. Ten names are to be chosen by lot from the families of citizens with more than one son under the age of ten, nominated by their father or grandfather ^{856e} on the father's or mother's side. The ten chosen names are to be sent to Delphi, and whomever the god selects is to be installed as the legal holder of the lot that has been vacated, and may better fortune attend it.

^{856e}

Clinias: Very good.

^{857a}

Athenian: There is to be one law like the last, a third law prescribing which judges should judge the cases and how the trials are to be conducted when people are brought to court on a charge of treason. And, in like manner, let there be a law about whether the offspring should remain in the country or leave, applicable alike to these three cases of temple-plundering, treason, and the forcible subversion of the laws of the city. For a thief, regardless of whether the theft is big or small, let there be only one law, and a single legal penalty in all cases. First, he is to pay twice the value of what was stolen once he has been convicted of such a crime, provided he has enough wealth over and above his holding to make the payment. If not, he is to be imprisoned until the fine is paid or he ^{857b} persuades the person who prosecuted him to release him. If someone is convicted of theft of public property, he shall be released from prison once he has persuaded the state to let him out or he has repaid

double the value of what was stolen.

857b

Clinias: How can we say, stranger, that it makes no difference to the thief's treatment whether he steals something big or small, from a sacred, holy place or from elsewhere, and that none of the other differences between the various kinds of theft matter? Surely the lawgiver should pay heed to the variations, and not impose similar penalties in every case?

857c

Athenian: Very good, Clinias. I was, so to speak, letting myself drift when you clashed with me and woke me up. You have reminded me of something I thought of previously, that the issues involved in setting down the laws have not been correctly worked out at all, and what has just happened confirms this. What do I mean? We didn't make a bad comparison earlier when we compared all law-making nowadays to medical treatment given by slaves to slaves. For you really need to appreciate that if one of those physicians who set about healing people through experience devoid of reason were to come across a physician who is free, conversing with a patient who is free, using arguments much like those used in philosophic discourse, dealing with the disease from its source, recapitulating in its entirety the nature of human bodies, he would laugh aloud on the spot. He would have nothing else to say on the matter besides the words that always spring so readily to the lips of most so-called physicians, for he would say, "Fool, you are not healing your patient, you are educating him as if he wanted to become a physician instead of becoming healthy."

857d

Clinias: Would he not be right to say so?

857e

Athenian: Perhaps he would, provided he also appreciated, in addition, that anyone who deals with laws in this way, just as we

are now doing, is educating the citizens rather than legislating for them. Wouldn't this observation also apparently be relevant?

Clinias: Perhaps.

Athenian: Our present predicament is a fortunate one then.

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: There is no necessity for us to make laws, but only to enter into an enquiry ourselves about political systems in general and attempt to see how what's best and what's essential may be brought about. And what's more, we are now seemingly in a position to consider what is best or what is essential in relation to laws, as we prefer. So we should make our choice.

858a

Clinias: We are presenting a ridiculous choice, stranger. Indeed, we would be behaving like lawgivers who are under pressure to pass laws there and then, by some urgent necessity, because tomorrow will be too late. But we are allowed, if I may say so, to act like stone masons, or anyone else who is starting to construct something. We may accumulate materials at random, from which we shall then choose what's suitable for what we intend to construct and, indeed, we may choose at our leisure. So, let's not put ourselves in the position of those who build under compulsion rather than doing so at their leisure, laying some materials aside for future use while using others to build with. And so we may rightly say that some of our laws are being enacted while others are being laid aside.

858b

Athenian: Well, Clinias, at least our review of the laws would be more natural. Indeed, we should look, by heavens, at an issue concerning lawmakers.

Clinias: Which is?

Athenian: There are writings and written speeches by lots of people in our cities, and there are writings and written speeches of the lawgivers too.

858c

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: Now, are we to pay serious attention to the writings of the various other authors, who have set down for posterity a written record, in verse or in prose, of their own advice concerning the conduct of life, while ignoring the writings of the lawgivers? Or should we attend to these most of all?

Clinias: Very much so.

858d

Athenian: There are many writers who advise us about what is noble, good and just, teaching us what these are and how they should be pursued by those who are intent upon a happy life. Surely the lawgiver can't be the sole exception.

Clinias: Of course not.

858e

Athenian: Well, in that case, is the disgrace greater for Homer, Tyrtaeus and the other authors if they did badly in setting down precepts about life and activities in their writings, but less of a disgrace for Lycurgus and Solon and any other lawgivers who have written down laws?⁹⁴

859a

Athenian: Or, more correctly, should all writings in our cities, written on the subject of laws, prove, when the scroll is unfolded, to be by far the most beautiful and excellent writings? Should the writings of others either conform to their standard, or else, if they are discordant with these legal writings, be a laughing stock? And how are we to think about writings dealing with the laws of our cities? Are they to appear in the guise of an affectionate and intelligent father or mother, or should they

give orders and issue threats, like a tyrannical despot, who writes his decrees on the walls and that is that? So, this is the question we now should consider. Should we, in thinking about the laws, try to state them in this gentler way, proceeding ^{859b} eagerly at any rate, whether we are up to the task or not? And in adopting this approach, are we to accept whatever predicament we end up in? May all be well, and God willing, all will indeed be well.

^{859b}

Clinias: Well said. We should do as you suggest.

Athenian: So, since we have set it in train, we should first conduct a detailed enquiry into the law concerning temple-plundering, theft in general, and injustices of all sorts, and not be dis- ^{859c} couraged if in the midst of passing our laws we find that we have already enacted some, while others are still under consideration. For we are in the process of becoming lawgivers, but we are not there yet, although we may perhaps succeed. So, if we agree to consider the issues I have spoken of, in the way that I have spoken of them, let's proceed to do so.

^{859c}

Clinias: Yes, certainly.

Athenian: There is something we should be clear about in relation to what is noble and just. To what extent do we agree with one another at the moment, and to what extent do we disagree? According to ourselves, we are eager at least to do better than most people, even if we achieve nothing else. But to what extent do the majority themselves disagree, for their part, ^{859d} among themselves?

^{859d}

Clinias: What sort of differences between us do you have in mind?

Athenian: I shall try to explain. In relation to justice in general – just people, just deeds and just behaviour – everyone agrees somehow that these are all noble. And so even if someone ^{859e} insists that just people who happen to have ugly bodies are yet utterly noble because their character is so very just, whoever says so would not really be too far wide of the mark it seems.

^{859e}

Clinias: Isn't this right?

Athenian: Perhaps. But let us take note that if everything possessed of justice is noble, 'everything' includes what is inflicted on us just as much as what we enact.

Clinias: What of it?

Athenian: An action that is just, insofar as it shares in justice, also to that extent participates in nobility.

Clinias: Indeed.

^{860a}

Athenian: And in accepting that an infliction that shares in justice is, to that extent, also noble, our language would be consistent, wouldn't it?

Clinias: True.

Athenian: But if we accept that a just infliction is ignoble, then what is just and what is noble will be inconsistent because we are then saying that what is just is utterly ignoble.

Clinias: What point are you making?

Athenian: Nothing that is hard to understand. Indeed, the laws we set down a little earlier seem to be saying the exact opposite to what's being said now.

Clinias: In what sense?

^{860b}

Athenian: We laid it down that the temple-plunderer, and the enemy of our duly enacted laws, may be put to death, and when we were about to enact many more regulations of this sort we held back. We saw a huge number of severe penalties being inflicted under these regulations, and that all these inflictions were most just, and at the same time ignoble in the extreme. Accordingly what is just and what is noble will look exactly the same to us at one moment, and directly opposite the next. Isn't this so?

Clinias: There is that danger.

860c

Athenian: And that is the inconsistent way that most people speak about these matters, setting apart what is just and what is noble.

Clinias: Apparently so, stranger.

Athenian: Well, let us look once more at our own position, Clinias. Where indeed does the consistency lie in relation to these very matters?

Clinias: What consistency? In relation to what?

Athenian: In our previous discussions, I think I stated explicitly somehow – or if I didn't say so before, you may take it that I am saying so now...

Clinias: Saying what?

860d

Athenian: That all bad people are always bad unintentionally. This being the case, the next point necessarily follows from this.

Clinias: What do you mean?

Athenian: That the unjust person is indeed bad, but the bad person does not intend to be like that. But it makes no sense that an intentional deed is done unintentionally, so for someone

who is of the view that injustice is unintentional, the person who acts unjustly does so unintentionally, and this is indeed the view I must now accept. For I agree that everyone does injustice unintentionally. And if someone out of contentiousness or because they want to be famous maintains that although some people are unjust unintentionally, many people intend to act unjustly, well that is not my argument. So how may I be consistent in my own argu- ^{860e} ments? Suppose you two, Megillus and Clinias, were to ask me, “If this is indeed how matters stand, stranger, what advice are you giving us regarding the legislative process for our city of Magnesia? Are we to enact laws or not?” “By all means,” I shall reply. “Now, will you make a distinction for them between intentional and unintentional injustices, and are we to impose greater penalties for the intentional transgressions and injustices, and lesser penalties for the others? Or should the penalties be equal for them all, because there are no intentional injustices whatsoever?”

^{860e}

Clinias: Yes, you are expressing that in the right way, stranger. So, what is the practical application of what you are now saying?

^{861a}

Athenian: Good question. Well, let us apply them first as follows.

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: Let us remind ourselves that we said just now, and rightly so, that we are utterly confused and inconsistent in relation to what is just. Bearing this in mind, let us ask ourselves a further question. Well then, there is a difficulty concerning these two which we have not resolved, nor have we defined what precisely the difference is between these two kinds of injustices, those that are intentional and those that are

unintentional. Every legislator who has ever appeared in any city has legislated for these two forms of injustice. And will the proposition we have just advanced say this much and walk away, laying down the law like some divine pronouncement which doesn't provide a supporting argument because it has ^{861b}spoken the truth? No, before making laws it is necessary to demonstrate that there are these two forms of injustice, and that the difference between them is other than what people imagine, so that whenever someone imposes a penalty in either case, anyone who follows what we are saying would be able, somehow or other, to decide what's appropriate to impose, and what isn't.

^{861c}

Clinias: That sounds good to us, stranger. Yes, we need to do one of two things. Either we deny that all injustices are unintentional, or else, having first made the appropriate distinctions, demonstrate that this is correct.

^{861d}

Athenian: Well, of these two options, there is one that I cannot accept at all. I cannot allow you to deny this because I think that this is where the truth lies, and so a denial would be unlawful and unholy. But how are there to be two, if the two don't differ as unintentional and intentional injustices? In that case, we must try to demonstrate the principle on some other basis.

Clinias: Entirely so, stranger. It is not possible for us to approach this issue in any other way.

^{861e}

Athenian: That is what we will do. So come on, then. When citizens are involved in communal activities and various interactions, they harm one another in lots of ways, so it seems, and in these cases there are countless instances of the intentional and the unintentional.

Clinias: Inevitably.

Athenian: No one should insist that all the harms are injustices and, accordingly, decide that the injustices involved in these harms are twofold, some being intentional, some unintentional. For on the whole, there are as many instances of the unintentional harms as there are inten- ^{862a} tional harms, and they are just as significant. But please consider whether I am making sense or talking utter nonsense in saying what I am about to say. For I am not saying, Megillus and Clinias, that if someone injures someone else unintentionally, without wanting to do so, he is acting unjustly even though he is doing so unintentionally. And I am not going to propose laws on that basis by treating this as an unintended injustice. Rather, I shall not designate this sort of harm as an injustice at all, regardless of whether it is of ^{862b} greater or lesser significance. But in many cases we shall say, if my opinion prevails, that the person responsible for a benefit that unfolds wrongly is acting unjustly. For, in general, my friends, even if someone gives anything at all to someone else, or indeed takes it from them, such an action should not be referred to in simple terms either as just or as unjust. Rather, the lawgiver needs to consider whether or not the person is benefiting another or harming them, in a just spirit and in a just manner. He must take these two factors into account, the injustice and the harm. He must do the best he can, by the laws, to make good ^{862c} the harm done. He should restore what has been undone, reconstruct what has fallen down, and make good the slaughter and the deep wounds. And when the harm has been atoned for by awarding compensation, he must constantly endeavour to use the laws to establish friendship in place of discord, among the perpetrators and their victims.

^{862c}

Clinias: Yes, very good.

Athenian: As for cases of unjust harm, and profit too, where someone treats another unjustly but causes him to profit from

that action, these are diseases of the soul, and when they are curable they are to be cured. And the curing of the injustice, according to us, should proceed as follows.

Clinias: How?

862d

Athenian: In such a way that if someone commits an injustice, great or small, the law will teach him and compel him never, intentionally, to dare to do such a deed again at all, or to do so very much less often, and, in addition, to pay for any harm done. The actual function of the 862e most sublime laws is to bring this about with words or deeds, employing pleasures and pains, honours and dishonours, financial penalties or gifts, or any means at all at the disposal of the lawgiver to induce a hatred of injustice and a love, rather than hatred, of justice itself. But if the lawgiver realises that someone is beyond cure in these respects, what penalty shall he impose in such cases, and under what law? He would recognise, I presume, in all such cases, that it is not better for the people themselves to continue living, and that their departure from this life benefits others in two ways: by acting as an example to others to avoid injustice, and by ridding the city of bad men. And so, in such cases and no others, the lawgiver needs to impose the death penalty as a punishment for the transgressions.

863a

Clinias: What you have said sounds most reasonable somehow. But it would be nice to hear a clearer account of how the distinction between injustice and harm, and between what's intentional and what's unintentional, have become so mixed up.

Athenian: Then, I must try to do as you ask and explain this. There is something about soul that you have surely discussed with one another, and heard about. There is innate in it one characteristic, or part of its nature, namely passion – a contentious, aggressive quality whose irrational force

frequently wreaks havoc.

863b

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: And, indeed, we do not speak of pleasure as being the same as passion. We maintain that it holds sway by using a power that is the opposite of this, always getting its own way through persuasion combined with deception.

Clinias: Very much so.

863c

Athenian: And if someone were to say that ignorance is a third cause of the transgressions, that would not be a lie. Now, it would be better if the lawgiver were to divide this in two, regarding its simple form as the cause of slight transgressions. The complex form of ignorance arises when a person is devoid of understanding, being gripped not only by ignorance, but by a belief that he is wise, as if he was completely knowledgeable about things he knows nothing about at all. This sort of ignorance, when accompanied by strength and power, the lawgiver regards as the cause of major, vile transgressions. But when it is accompanied by 863d weakness, he will see that it is the cause of transgressions belonging to childishness or old age. And although he will indeed regard these as offences, and will pass laws as if these people were transgressors, these will be the most gentle and forgiving laws of all.

863d

Clinias: That sounds reasonable.

Athenian: Now, we all speak generally of one person as being in control of pleasure and passion, and another as controlled by them, and this is indeed how matters stand.

Clinias: Entirely so.

Athenian: But we have never heard it said that one person is in control of his ignorance while another is controlled by it.

Clinias: Very true.

863e

Athenian: And yet we say that when his own will is taking him in one direction, all these frequently urge the person in the opposite direction.

Clinias: Yes, with great frequency.

Athenian: Well then, I should now define for you, clearly and without complication, what I mean by just and unjust. For I refer to the tyranny in the soul of passion and fear, of pleasure and pain, envy and desire, whether they cause harm or not, as injustice in all cases. But when the opinion as to what's best is dominant in souls, and orders the lives of everyone – whatever a city or some citizens believe this to be – then, even if damage is done, anything that 864a is done in this way, and whatever is obedient to such rule, should be declared just and best, all in all, for the lives of us humans, even though the sort of harm I refer to is regarded by most people as unintended injustice. But our concern at the moment is not with some contentious argument about names. Rather, since it has been demonstrated that there are three 864b forms of transgressions, we should first get an even better mental grasp of these. One form is pain, which we call passion and fear.

864b

Clinias: Very much so.

864c

Athenian: The second consists of pleasure, and desires too. The third, which is quite different, is the striving for hopes, and true opinion about what is best. And when this one is itself divided in three, we have five forms, as we are now saying.⁹⁵ Different laws in each case should be enacted for these five, in two categories.

Clinias: What are these two?

Athenian: One consists of any deeds involving outright violence, the other of deeds done secretly with dark deception. There are also deeds that involve both aspects, and in such a case the laws should be at their harshest if they are to play their proper role.

Clinias: Yes, that's reasonable.

864d

Athenian: Next, let's return to the point from which we digressed, and continue the enactment of our laws. We had, I believe, put laws in place about plundering of the gods' property, about treason, and about the subversion of the laws in order to destroy the established constitution. Now, someone might engage in one of these whilst mad or under the influence of disease or extreme old age or out of immaturity, which are not much different from madness. If any ^{864e} of these circumstances comes to the notice of the selected judges, on the report of the offender himself or someone acting on his behalf, and it is adjudged that he broke the law whilst in this condition of madness, he should simply pay in full for any harm he has done to anyone, and any other penalties are to be waived. However, if he has killed someone and his hands have not been cleansed of the murder, he is in that case to be banished to another country, and dwell in that foreign place as an exile. Should he return before the time specified by law, or if he even sets foot in his native land, he is to be imprisoned in the state prison by the guardians of the law, and released only after two years.

865a

Athenian: Now that we have begun on the subject of murder, let us try to enact laws in full concerning all of its forms, dealing first with cases of unintentional violence. If someone causes the death of a friend in a contest or during public competitions, whether the person dies on the spot or later on from his

wounds, or the same thing happens in war or during military training when practising with the body unprotected, or in full armour when imitat- ^{865b} ing actual warfare, he may be pronounced pure once he has been purified in accord with a law received from Delphi concerning these cases. And in the case of physicians, if the patient dies unintentionally at their hands, let the law account the physician pure. If one person, by his own act, unintentionally kills someone else, either unarmed using his own body or using some implement or missile, or by giving the person food or drink, or by exposing him to heat or cold or suffocating him, whether he does this himself ^{865c} in person or through the agency of others, in any case the act should be treated as if it was his own act in every respect, and penalties should be imposed as follows. If he kills a slave he is to compensate the dead man's master for any damage or loss, treating the matter as if a slave of his own had been done away with. Otherwise, he is to incur a penalty of double the value of the dead slave, as determined by the judges, and undergo purifications that are greater and more numerous than in cases where people cause death during competitions.

^{865d}

Athenian: And interpreters whom the god selects are to be in charge of these purifications. If the slain slave was his own, he is to be acquitted once he has been purified according to the law. If someone unintentionally kills a free man, he is to undergo the same purifications as someone who kills a slave, and he should respect the ancient story, recounted of old. This tells us that someone who has suffered a violent death, having lived his life proud and free, is angry, ^{865e} just after death, with the person who did the deed. He is filled with fear and dread because ^{866a} of his own violent fate, and when he sees his own murderer frequenting his own familiar haunts, he is maddened, and, being disturbed himself, with memory as his ally, he troubles the perpetrator as much as he possibly can, both the man himself

and all his actions. For this reason, the perpetrator should avoid the victim for all the seasons of a single year, by vacating any places that are personal to the man throughout his native land. And if the man who died was foreign, he is also to refrain from visiting that foreign country for the same period of time. If someone complies willingly with this law, the dead man's closest kin, ^{866b} supervising all of these developments, are to forgive him, and in making peace with the offender they would be acting reasonably in every respect. But if someone does not comply, and first has the audacity to enter the sacred places and offer sacrifice without being purified, or again fails to fulfil the period of exile as decreed, the dead man's closest kin are to prosecute the killer for murder, and if he is convicted, all the penalties are to be doubled. And if his closest relative does not pursue the case, anyone who wishes may take a case against him, demanding five years of exile from his own native land as the legal penalty, as if the defilement had come around to the kinsman.

^{866c}

Athenian: If a foreigner unintentionally slays another foreigner, anyone in the city who wishes may prosecute him under the same laws, and if he has alien residency rights he is to be exiled for a year. But if he is an alien in every respect, whether a foreigner, a resident alien or a citizen was slain, in addition to the purification he is to be excluded for his entire life from the country where these laws hold sway. And if he returns illegally, the guardians of the law are to impose the death penalty upon him, and if he has any property this should be handed over to the victim's closest kindred. If he returns unintentionally because of a shipwreck off our coast, he is to encamp where the sea wets ^{866d} his feet, and keep watch for a ship to take him away. If he returns by land because some people have taken him here by force, the first city official who comes across him is to release him, and send him safely across

the border. If someone by his own hand slays a free-born citizen, but the deed is done in passion, we should begin by making a twofold distinction. For such a deed is done out of passion in one case by those who suddenly, and without planning the killing in advance, take someone's life in a spur-of-the-moment attack with blows or the like, and are remorseful as soon ^{866c} as the deed is done. In another case it is done out of passion by those who, having been insulted with words or disrespectful behaviour, pursue their revenge and eventually take someone's life, fully intending to kill, and are not remorseful over what has been done. It seems then we should treat these as two kinds of murder, both born more or less of passion, and it would be only right to say that they fall somewhere between the intentional and the unintentional. Not that they don't bear a resemblance to the two extremes. One resembles the intentional, in that the person nurses his passion and does not take revenge suddenly on ^{867a} the spur of the moment, but later on as part of a plan. The other, while not being entirely unintentional, does resemble the unintentional. The person is out of control, giving vent to his anger suddenly, on the spur of the moment, without advance planning, just like the unintentional murderer. Therefore, it is difficult to decide whether murders done in passion are to be treated by the law as intentional or, in a sense, unintentional. The best and truest course is to treat them both as resemblances, and distinguish them by the presence or absence of premeditation. Those who kill in anger, with premeditation, should be punished more harshly by the law, while those who do so suddenly, on the spur of the moment, should be ^{867b} treated more gently. For the deed that resembles the greater evil should receive the greater punishment, while the deed that resembles the lesser should be punished less. Our laws ^{867c} then must act accordingly.

^{867c}

Clinias: Entirely so.

Athenian: Well, returning to our theme once more, let us say this. If someone slays a free-born citizen by his own hand, whoever does so in anger, without premeditation, should suffer in general the fate deserved by someone who kills without passion, but he should be compelled ^{867d} to go into exile for two years, restraining his own passion. Someone who slays out of passion, but with premeditation, is to be treated much the same as the previous person, except that he is to be exiled for three years, rather than the two years in the other case, the greater passion receiving a longer term of punishment. Their return from exile should be dealt with as follows. Now, it is difficult to enact such laws in a precise manner since, of the two, the person treated by the law as more dangerous might, on occasion, be less aggressive, while ^{867e} the person it treats as less aggressive might be more dangerous and have carried out the murder more savagely, while the other was less aggressive. However, for the most part, what happens is in accord with what we have just been saying. So, the guardians of the law are to act as arbiters in all these cases, once the period of exile is over. In either case, they are to send twelve judges from among themselves to the country's borders, judges who have, during the period of exile, looked into the actions of the exiles in even greater detail. They are to act as judges concerning the forgiveness and the return home of these offenders, ^{868a} who are, for their part, to abide by whatever is decided by such officials. If either of the two, having returned home, ever lets anger get the better of him and does the same thing again, let him be exiled, never to return. And if he does return, let him suffer the same fate as a returning foreigner. If someone kills his own slave, he is to be purified, and if he kills someone else's slave out of passion, he is to pay double damages to the owner. If any killer of any sort dis- ^{868b} regards this law and defiles the market place, the games or the other sacred places by being impure when he goes there, anyone who wishes may prosecute the

responsible member of the dead man's family, and the killer too, and compel them in one case to demand, and in the other case to pay, double the fine and other penalties. And let the fine be payable, by law, to the person who prosecuted them. Should a slave kill his own master out of passion, ^{868c} the relatives of the dead man may treat the killer as they please; except to be pure, they are under no circumstances to leave him alive. If some other slave, out of passion, kills a free citizen, his masters are to hand the slave over to the relatives of the dead man who must put the murderer to death, but may do so in any way they please. If, as sometimes happens, but not often, a father or mother, out of passion, slays a son or daughter with blows or by some other violent means, let them be purified by the ^{868d} same procedures as in the other cases, and be exiled for a period of three years. When such killers return, a woman is to separate from her husband and a man from his wife, and they are not to have any more children together. Nor may they share a home with those whom they have robbed of a child or a brother, nor may they join in their sacred rituals. Anyone who disrespects and disregards these requirements may be prosecuted for impiety by who- ^{868e} ever wishes. If some man in anger kills his own wedded wife, or a woman does the very same thing to her husband in the same way, let them undergo the same purifications and be exiled for three years. On their return, someone who has done such a deed may not join in the sacred rituals of their own children, nor share their table. If either the parent or the child disregards these requirements, they are to be prosecuted for impiety by anyone who pleases. If, out of passion, brother slays brother or sister, or sister slays brother or sister, they ^{869a} are to undergo the same purifications and period of exile as decreed for the parents and the offspring. No one may ever share the home or join in the sacred rituals with brothers whom they have deprived of brothers, or parents whom they have deprived of their children. If anyone

disregards this precept, it is only right and just that they be prosecuted under the law as stated concerning impiety in such cases.

869b

Athenian: If someone develops such uncontrolled passion directed against those who gave him life, that in the madness of anger he dares to slay one of his parents, and the victim, just before death, willingly forgives the perpetrator of murder, then let him be accounted pure once he has undergone the same purifications as those who have committed an unintentional murder, and has done everything else that is required in those cases. If he is not forgiven, then whoever has done such a deed must be subject to a number of laws, for he would be liable to penalties in the extreme, for assault, for impiety, and for temple plundering too, ^{869c} because he has stolen the soul of his parent. And so, if it were possible for the same person to die many times, then it would be perfectly just for a patricide or matricide, who did the deed out of passion, to suffer many deaths. Indeed, in this case alone, even in self-defence where his life is under threat from his parents, no law will permit the slaying of a father or mother, the very people who are responsible for his existence. The law will ordain that he put up with anything rather than do such a deed. How else under the law could such a person be punished appropriately? So let the death penalty stand as the punishment for someone who slays his father or mother out of passion.

869d

Athenian: If, during some civil faction, a brother slays a brother during a fight or the like, while defending himself against someone who started the trouble, let him be accounted pure, just as if he had killed an enemy. The same applies to the killing of a citizen by a citizen, or a foreigner by a foreigner. If a citizen slays a foreigner, or a foreigner a citizen, in self-defence, the procedures for purification are to be the same, and likewise if a

slave kills a slave. But if, on the other hand, a slave kills a free-born citizen in self-defence, he is to be subject to the same laws as someone who kills his father. What has been said about the forgiveness of ^{869e} murder on the part of a dying father is also to apply to all forgiveness of such offences. If anyone willingly forgives anyone else for this, as though the murder has been unintentional, the offender is to undergo the purifications, and the period of exile under the law is to be for one year. Let that stand as a reasonable treatment of murders that are violent, unintentional and born of passion. We must now add to these our treatment of murders that are intentional and born of total injustice, that are premeditated and performed under the dominion of pleasures, desires and jealousies.

^{869e}

Clinias: Quite right.

^{870a}

Athenian: Once again, then, let us begin by stating, as best we can, how many such causes there are. The greatest is desire, which dominates a soul made wild by its own longings. Now, this is strongest when the object of the most frequent and powerful yearning that affects most people is present. Because of their bad nature and ill education, the power of wealth is such as to breed countless passions in people for its own insatiable and unchecked acquisition. And the cause of the ill education is the custom, among Greeks and non-Greeks alike, of praising wealth in a perverse manner. For by deciding that it is the foremost of goods, when ^{870b} it really lies third, they do harm to the succeeding generations and to themselves. The most exalted and excellent practice of all, for any city, is to speak the truth about wealth, which is that it exists for the sake of the body, and the body for the sake of the soul. So since there are these goods, and wealth exists for their sake, it would lie in third place after the excellence of body and soul. Now, this precept would teach us that someone intent upon a happy life

^{870c} should seek not to be wealthy, but to be wealthy in a just and sound-minded manner, and in this way, murders requiring further murders as a purification would not take place in our cities. Nowadays, however, as we said at the outset of these deliberations, this love of wealth is the single most significant factor responsible for the most serious court cases involving intentional murder. Second is the disposition of an ambitious soul, producing jealousies that are particularly difficult even for the jealous person himself to live with, and difficult too for the best people in the city.

^{870d}

Athenian: In third place are the fears born of cowardice and injustice that lead to so many murders in cases where someone is doing, or has done, something they wouldn't want anyone else to know about, so they do away with those who might expose such secret deeds by killing them when they are unable to stop them in any other way. Let what has been said so far be preludes dealing with all these matters, to which we should add the account, firmly believed by many, who have heard it from those who have concerned themselves with this sort of thing in the sacred mysteries. The account states ^{870e} that in Hades there is retribution for such transgressions, and that on returning to this world once more, the offender must pay the natural penalty, the penalty of experiencing the crime he himself committed, thus ending his present life by suffering that very fate at the hands of another.

^{871a}

Athenian: There is no need to recount the full law on this matter to someone who is convinced, and totally dreads such a penalty. But for anyone who is not convinced, let the law declare in writing, that whoever by his own hand slays a fellow citizen with premeditation, in an unjust manner, is, in the first place, to be excluded from the lawful assemblies and is not to defile the sacred places, the market, the harbours or any public

meeting with his presence, whether someone notifies the offender of these exclusions or not. In fact, the law notifies ^{871b} him on behalf of the entire city, and does so publicly, and will continue to do so. If anyone closely related to the deceased, on his father's or mother's side, as close as a cousin, who should prosecute the killer doesn't do so, or fails to proclaim his exclusion, firstly, the defilement should fall upon that person, and the wrath of the gods too, for the wrath of the law brings infamy with it. Secondly, he is liable to prosecution by anyone who wishes to exact punishment on behalf of the deceased. Whoever is prepared to exact punishment should ^{871c} pay due attention to the relevant ablutions and whatever other requirements the god has ordained in these cases, and give formal notice of the proceedings. He should then go on to compel the offender to submit to the imposition of the penalty, according to law. Now, the lawgiver may declare, quite easily, that this must all be brought about through certain prayers and sacrifices to the gods who are concerned, that no murders take place in our cities. But who these gods are, and what manner of prosecuting such cases would be most correct in relation to the divine, shall be ordained, in conjunction with inter- ^{871d} preters, prophets and the god, by those who make the laws, who should conduct these cases accordingly. And the judges of these cases shall be the same as those who were said to have full authority to try the temple plunderers. Whoever is found guilty is to be sentenced to death, and is not to be buried in the land of his victim, for quite apart from the impiety, such a burial would imply forgiveness. If he flees and is not prepared to submit to judgement, let him flee and be an exile forever. But if any such person sets foot in the land of the murder ^{871e} victim, the first relative or fellow citizen of the deceased that comes across him may kill him with impunity, or else tie him up and hand him over to the officials who tried the case, to be put to death. Whoever is prosecuting a case must, at the outset, secure a

guarantee from the person he is accusing, who should provide guarantors, worthy people in the opinion of the court that tries such cases. Three such worthy guarantors are to guarantee to present him for trial. And if the accused is unwilling or unable to make such an arrangement, the ^{872a} court shall apprehend him, keep him in prison, and present him for trial. If someone does not commit a murder by his own hand, but nevertheless plots the death of another person, and having killed him through planning and contrivance continues to dwell in the city, responsible for murder but with his soul unpurified, let him be subject to the same judicial procedures as the previous case except in the matter of the guarantee, and let's allow him be buried in his own native land. In all other respects the procedure in his case is to be the same as in the previous case.⁹⁶ These same procedures apply, apart from the guarantee, to killings in person or through contrivance, involving foreigners against foreigners, citizens and foreigners against one another, or, indeed, slaves against slaves. The ^{872b} guarantee, as we said, is to be obtained by those who kill in person, and so whoever makes the accusation of murder must demand a guarantee in these cases too. But if a slave intentionally slays a free citizen, either in person or through contrivance, and he is found guilty of the crime, the public executioner is to drag him towards the burial place of the deceased, to a place where the tomb is visible, and lash him as many times as the accuser ordained. And if he is still alive after being whipped, he is to be put to death. If someone kills a slave who has done no wrong, fearing that he might expose the man's own disgraceful, evil deeds, or from some similar motivation, let him stand trial for the murder of such a slave in just the same way as if he had slain a fellow citizen.

^{872c}

Athenian: Now, there are cases for which the framing of laws is a dreadful and utterly distasteful task, yet it is impossible to

avoid enacting them. I am referring to murders of close relatives, either in person or through contrivance, that are intentional and unjust in every way. These occur for the most part in cities that are badly governed, where people are badly brought up, but something like this may happen even in a country where you might least expect it. So we should repeat the account we gave a moment ago in the hope that someone who hears us may be better able under such guidance, to refrain of their own accord from murders that contravene every sacred precept. For the story or account, or whatever it should ^{872d} be called, comes from priests of old, and declares plainly that justice, the avenger of the blood of kinfolk, keeps watch using the law we have just stated, and decrees that whoever does such a deed must of necessity suffer that very same fate himself. If someone ever kills his father, he himself must submit to suffering the same violent death sometime at the hands of his own offspring. If he slays his mother, he himself must be born with a female nature, and in due course lose his life at the hands of those to whom he gave birth. For once the shared blood has been defiled, there is no other purification besides this, and the stain of pollution will refuse to be washed away until the offending soul has paid the price, murder ^{872e} for murder, like for like, and has brought the anger of all the kinfolk to rest by appeasing them. So, dreading such vengeance from the gods, a person should show restraint. If, however, any people are overtaken by such wretched misfortune as to deprive a father or mother, siblings or offspring, of their human body, with premeditation and full intent, the law enacted by the mortal lawgiver should decree the following. The proclamations of their exclusion from lawful assemblies, and the guarantees, are to be the same as described in the previous cases. And if someone is found guilty of such a murder, having slain one of ^{873a} these kinfolk, the judges' assistants and the officials are to put him to death and throw his body at a place outside the city

where three roads meet. There all the officials, on behalf of the entire city, each bearing a stone, are to throw it at the head of the corpse to sanctify the whole city. Afterwards, by law, the body is to be carried beyond the boundaries of the country, and cast out unburied.

873b

Athenian: But what is to happen to someone who slays the closest kindred of all, the dearest of all, so called? I am referring to someone who kills himself, violently depriving fate of its destined course without the city's just decree, without being compelled to do so because he has been afflicted by huge, inescapable pain, without being involved in some desperate disgrace that he cannot live with; someone who, out of idleness and unmanly cowardice, passes an unjust sentence upon himself. In this case then, in general, god knows the observances ^{873c} that are required in relation to purification and burial. The closest kindred should make enquiry about these from the interpreters, and from the relevant laws, and act in accordance with their injunctions. The graves of those who have met their end in this way are firstly to be solitary. There must be no shared tombs. And they are to be buried ignominiously, with no headstones or names visible on their graves, on unnamed waste land between the borders of the twelve regions.

873d

Athenian: Now, if a beast of burden or some other animal murders someone – except when it does something like this while competing in the public games – the relatives shall prosecute the killer for murder and the case is to be judged by those rural commissioners, in whatever number, whom the relatives appoint. The guilty animal is to be killed and cast out beyond the country's borders.

873e

Athenian: What if something lifeless deprives a human being of life? Except in the case of lightning or some such dart from god, any other object that kills someone by falling on him, or because he falls against it, is to be tried by the man's nearest neighbour at the behest of his closest relative, who is thus purified, himself and the whole family. The offending item is then to be cast out beyond the boundaries, just as we described in the case of animals.

874a

Athenian: If someone has obviously been slain and it is not apparent who killed him, and this is not discovered even after a careful investigation, the same notices of trial are to be served, just as in the other cases, but the prosecutor should make his public address to “the person ^{874b} who committed the murder”, and having established his right to prosecute, shall announce in the market place that “whoever killed so and so’ is guilty of murder and is not to enter the sacred places, nor anywhere in the country of his victim. And if he does make an appearance and is recognised, he shall be put to death and cast out, unburied, outside the country of his victim. So let this stand as one of our established laws, one dealing with murder. So far we have dealt with cases of this sort, in this way. But the cases and circumstances where a killer may properly be accounted pure are as follows. If someone slays a ^{874c} thief whom he catches entering his house by night to steal his property, let him be accounted pure. If someone kills a robber in self-defence, let him be pure. If someone is doing violence to a free-born woman or boy, sexually, he may be slain with impunity by those who are being forcibly violated, or by their father, brothers or sons. If a man finds his wedded wife being violated and he kills the perpetrator, let him be pure in the eyes of the law. And if anyone slays someone while defending his father's life when his father is doing nothing improper, or indeed when defending his mother or children or brothers or the mother of his children, let

him be accounted pure, entirely so.

874d

Athenian: Let us take it, then, that laws are in place for punishments in cases of violent death and for the upbringing and education of the living soul, which makes life liveable when present, and the very opposite when absent. And although the laws that deal with the nature and education of bodies have been described, what follows from these – the violent actions against one another that occur intentionally or unintentionally – must be distinguished as best we can, stating what they are and how many there are, and what the appropriate punishments are in each case. It seems only right to legislate for these matters as well as the others. Now, even the most incompetent practitioner of the law would place cases of injuring 875a and consequent maiming next, after cases involving death. Injuries must be distinguished in the same way that murders were distinguished, some being unintentional, born of passion or fear, others being intentional and premeditated. But everything of this sort requires a prefatory statement explaining that it is, indeed, necessary for us humans to enact laws, and to live according to those laws, or else be no different from the wildest of wild beasts. The reason for this is that there is no human being whose nature is so fully developed as to recognise what is beneficial to humanity in civic terms, and having recognised this be capable 875b of doing what is best, always and willingly. Indeed, it is difficult to recognise, firstly, that the true science of politics needs to care not for the private but for the common interest, for what's common unites the cities, while the private tears them asunder. And it is hard to recognise too that it is beneficial, both to the community and to the individual, that the common be given priority over the private. Secondly, even someone who arrives at an adequate recognition that this is the natural state of affairs in theory, and afterwards rules the city unchecked, answering to none but

himself, would never be able to abide by that precept, ^{875c} and spend his time fostering common interests in the city while placing his personal interests second. Rather, his mortal nature will drive him to greed and self-interest, fleeing from pain and pursuing pleasure in an irrational manner, giving higher priority to these two than to justice and goodness, producing its own darkness, and finally filling itself and the entire city with all sorts of evils. Of course, if any person was ever born, by divine providence naturally equipped with the ability to appreciate these truths, no laws would be needed to govern him. For no law or command is more authoritative than knowledge, nor is it ordained ^{875d} that reason be subservient to anything, or be its slave. Reason should have authority over everything, if it really is as it naturally is, true and free. But nowadays this appreciation is nowhere to be found, or is quite rare, so we must take the second-best course – command and law. These two can discern a great deal, and attend to a great deal, but not to everything. All this has been said because we are now deciding what should happen to the person who injures or harms someone else, and what ^{875e} the penalty should be. At this stage, anyone might quite rightly interject, and ask in general, “What injury does this person do, to whom, how, and when?” For there are countless possibilities here, and they differ enormously from one another. Now, it is impossible to entrust all these issues to the law courts for judgement, or to entrust none of them. Indeed, in all cases one issue that must be entrusted to them for judgement is the question of whether each of these events happened or did not happen. And it is well-nigh impossible to avoid entrusting them with the further decision on the penalty for the wrongdoers, and what they ^{876a} must suffer in any of these cases. And it is impossible too for the lawgiver to enact laws for all these cases, great and small, himself.

^{876a}

Clinias: After this, what precept comes next?

Athenian: That some matters should be entrusted to the courts, while others should rather be legislated for by the lawgiver.

Clinias: Which matters should be legislated for, and which should be handed over to the law courts for judgement?

876b

Athenian: It would be more correct to make the following point next. Consider a city where the law courts are degenerate and inarticulate, where they don't disclose their members' opinions, where judgements are given secretly, and to make matters worse are made not in silent proceedings but amidst tumult, as if in a theatre, with shouts of approval or disapproval of each of the speakers in turn. All this tends to be a difficult predicament for the entire city.

876c

Athenian: To take on the task of enacting laws for courts of this sort, under pressure of necessity, is a most unfortunate position to be in. Nevertheless, having taken on the task out of necessity, we should trust the courts to assign penalties in the insignificant cases, while most cases are dealt with explicitly by formal legislation, if that is, one would ever legislate for such a society at all. But in a city where, to the best of its ability, the courts have been properly established, and the people who are to act as judges have been well trained and tested in every detail, it would be right and sensible to trust judges of this sort, for the most part, to decide what is to happen to offenders, and what penalties they should incur. No one should ^{876d} blame us then, in the present case, if we do not prescribe for them by law the various important principles which even less educated judges would be well able to discern, and then impose upon each of the transgressors the deserved penalty for the injury suffered and the crime committed. That is because the judges for whom we are making laws are, in our view, more than

capable of deciding such matters for themselves, and should be trusted to do so in most cases. Of course, we cannot avoid the approach stated and acted upon so often previously in the implementation of our laws by providing an outline and giving samples of the punishments as examples to the judges, so that they do not transgress the bounds of justice. That was the right thing to do then, and that's what should be done now, as I return once more to consideration of laws.

877a

Athenian: Let our enactment about wounding be as follows. If someone plans and intends to slay a friendly party, apart from those whom the law opposes, and he fails to kill him but wounds him instead, the person who planned the murder and inflicted the injury deserves no mercy. And there should be no concern about treating him just as if he had killed someone, and making him stand trial for murder. But we should show respect for the fact that his misfortune was not total, and respect too for the daimon who took pity on him and on the person he injured by acting as their saviour so that the injury did not prove fatal in one case, and that the misfortune did not turn into a curse in the other case. So, out of gratitude ^{877b} and submission to the daimon, the offender should be spared the death penalty, and exiled instead to a neighbouring state to live out his life there, enjoying all of his own possessions in full. If he has damaged the injured party, let him make payment to the person he has damaged, and let the amount be assessed by the court that judges the case, a court consisting of the judges who would have decided the murder case if the victim had died of his wounds.

877c

Athenian: If a son intentionally wounds a parent, or a slave his master, let the penalty be death. And if a brother wounds a brother or sister, or a sister does the same, and they are found guilty of wounding with intent, let the penalty be death. If a man wounds his own wife, or a woman her husband, while

intending to kill them, they are to be exiled in perpetuity. If they have any sons or daughters who are still children, their property is to be entrusted to trustees who should look after the children as orphans. If the children are adults, they should be under no obligation to support the exiled parent, and the property should belong to them.

877d

Athenian: If such disasters befall someone who is childless, there should be a meeting of relatives on both sides, the male and the female, extending as far as children of cousins, to decide upon an inheritor for this holding – a 5,040th part of the city – in conjunction with the guardians of the law and the priests. They are to bear in mind the general principle that of the 5,040 holdings, none belongs to the occupier or even to his entire family as much as it belongs, as public and as private property, to the city itself. And the city must, as best it ^{877e} can, preserve the sanctity and good fortune of its own holdings. So, whenever a household suffers such misfortune and ignominy at the same time, to such an extent that the possessor, unwed or married, without offspring, dies, having been sentenced to death for wilful murder or some other such offence against the gods or the community, for which the death penalty has been expressly prescribed by law, or when a man with no children is in exile in perpetuity, this holding must first be purified and exorcised in accordance with the law. Then the ^{878a} members of his household are to meet together, as we described just now, along with the guardians of the law, to discover the family in the city that is held in the highest esteem for its excellence, and is fortunate too, and in which there are a number of children. From this family they shall give one child up for adoption to succeed the father of the dead person and his lineage, naming him after one of them as an omen, praying that by so doing he may become a source of offspring for them, a guardian of the hearth, who cares for everything holy and sacred, enjoying better fortune

than his adoptive father. This person is to be installed by law as the heir to the holding, while the offender, when such misfortunes befall him, is allowed to lie nameless, childless and portionless.

878b

Athenian: It is not the case it seems, under all circumstances, that one boundary line is always adjacent to another boundary line. In some cases there is an intervening space between the boundaries, touching either of the two first, as it lies midway between them. And, indeed, we said that a deed done in anger is like this, as it lies between the intentional and the unintentional. So our law about wounding in anger should be as follows. If someone is found guilty, he is to pay double damages if the injury turns out to be curable, and quadruple damages if it is incurable. And if, although it is curable, the wounded party suffers enormous shame and embarrassment, quadruple damages are to be paid.

878c

Athenian: When someone inflicts injuries that not only harm the victim, but the city too, by rendering the victim incapable of defending his fatherland in time of war, he is to compensate the city for the damage, in addition to the other penalties. For as well as his own military service, he should also do service on behalf of the incapacitated person, and take on the military duties in his place. If he fails to do so, anyone who wishes may take a legal action against him for evasion of military service. The amount of any damages, whether they are to be double, triple, or quadruple, should be determined by the judges who found him guilty in the first place.

878d

Athenian: If kindred in like manner injures kindred, then the parents and the relatives, as far as the children of cousins, on both the male and female side, are all to meet together, men and women alike, and having judged the case are to entrust the

decision on the penalty to the natural parents. If the penalty is disputed, the male relatives are authorised to decide the penalty, and if they are unable to do so themselves, they should finally entrust the decision ^{878e} to the guardians of the law. In cases where such injuries are inflicted on parents by their offspring, the judges need to be over sixty years of age, with natural children of their own, not adopted. If the defendant is found guilty, they are to decide whether such a person should be put to death, or suffer some more severe, or even slightly less severe, punishment. None of the relatives of the offender are to judge the case, not even if they have reached the age stipulated by the law.

^{879a}

Athenian: If a slave wounds a free citizen in anger, the owner is to hand the slave over to the injured party to do with him as he pleases, and if he doesn't hand him over, he himself is to make good the damage. If someone alleges that what happened was a conspiracy hatched by the slave and the injured party, he must sustain that allegation in court. If he fails he shall pay triple damages, but if he succeeds he shall secure an action for kidnapping, against whoever devised the conspiracy in conjunction with the slave. If someone injures someone ^{879b} else unintentionally, let him pay the simple damage, for no lawgiver is up to the task of controlling the operation of chance, and the judges shall be those prescribed for cases where children injure their parents, and they shall assess the value of the damages payable.

^{879c}

Athenian: All the cases we have just spoken of involve violence, and assault too, as a general category, also involves violence. Now, in relation to such behaviour, every man, woman and child must always bear in mind that the elder is revered much more than the younger, among the gods, and among people who intend to live a safe and happy life. So, an assault

perpetrated in public by the younger on the elder is a disgraceful act to behold, and one detested by the gods. So, it is most becoming for a younger person who is struck by an ^{879d} older person to endure the anger with equanimity, thus storing up such respect himself for his own old age. Let our principle be that everyone is to revere everyone older than himself, in word and in deed. Any man or woman more than twenty years his senior is to be regarded as his father or mother and treated with care. All, who because of their age are capable of having begotten him or given him birth, are to be shown restraint for the sake of the gods of birth. In like manner, restraint should be exercised with a foreigner, whether he is a long-term resident or newly arrived. Indeed, neither as the aggressor nor in self-defence, under any circumstances, should a citizen dare to chastise such a person with blows. And if he himself has been assaulted outrageously and audaciously by a foreigner, who he believes ^{879e} should be punished, he is not to retaliate, but to apprehend the foreigner and bring him before a court of city commissioners so that he may learn never to be so bold as to assault a native citizen. The commissioners, having taken the foreigner in hand and cross-examined him with due respect for the god of strangers, are, if the foreigner proves to have unjustly beaten the native, to lash him just as many times as he himself struck the native to put a stop to this foreign audacity. If he has not acted unjustly, they shall warn and censure the man who brought him in, and send both on their way. If someone assaults someone of the ^{880a} same age as himself, or someone who is older but childless, whether elder strikes elder or younger strikes younger, natural self-defence with bare hands, devoid of weapons, may be employed. If someone over forty years of age dares to engage in a fight, either as the aggressor or in self-defence, the degrading punishment of being regarded as wild, unworthy of freedom, and little better than a slave, is no more than he deserves.

880b

Athenian: Someone who readily accepts such exhortation will be easy to deal with, while someone who resists and thinks nothing of our prelude should readily accept the following law. If anyone assaults someone who is twenty years older than himself, or more, firstly, whoever comes across them and is not the same age, or younger, is to separate them or else be an evildoer in the eyes of the law. And if he is the same age, or even younger, let him come to the defence of the victim, as if he were his brother or father or elder relative. Furthermore, whoever dares to attack an elder, as described, is to be tried for assault, and if he is found ^{880c} guilty he is to be imprisoned for at least a year, and if the judges impose a longer sentence that penalty is binding. If a foreigner or a resident alien strikes someone who is twenty years older than himself or more, the same laws relating to assistance from bystanders shall have the same force. For anyone who is convicted of such an offence, who is a foreigner without residency rights, the penalty should be two years imprisonment. A resident alien who dis- ^{880d} obeys these laws should be imprisoned for three years, unless the court decides to impose a longer sentence upon him. A bystander who doesn't render assistance in such cases, as prescribed by law, is to be fined one mina for those of the highest property class, fifty drachmas for the second highest, thirty for the third, and twenty for the fourth. And the court in such cases should consist of generals, army commanders, cavalry officers and cavalry commanders.

880e

Athenian: Some laws it seems are aimed at worthy folk, to teach them a manner of dealing with one another that will ensure that they live wisely. Other laws are aimed at people who reject education, who are hard by nature and devoid of the softness required to avoid going the way of total evil. These people are responsible for whatever we are about to state, since

the lawgiver needs to enact certain laws for them, wishing all the while that they were not needed. Whoever dares to lay hands upon father or mother or their progenitors in a violent ^{881a} assault, fearing neither the wrath of the gods above nor the punishments reported in the world below, acting as if he knows when he does not know at all about these matters, who transgresses the law out of contempt for the ancient and universal traditions, is someone who requires the ultimate deterrent. Now, death is not the ultimate deterrent. The travails described for such offences in Hades are much more extreme than those in this world, but although they are recounted in great detail, they do not act as a deterrent for souls like these, for if they did, these unholy, flagrant assaults upon mothers and ancestors would never occur. So, the punishments of these people for such offences in this life, should, if possible, not fall short of those in Hades.

^{881b}

Athenian: Let our next pronouncement, then, be as follows. If someone who is not in the grip of madness dares to strike their father or mother, their grandfather or grandmother, firstly, as in the previous cases, any bystander must render assistance. A foreigner with residency rights who helps shall be called to the seats of honour at the public games, or shall be exiled from the country in perpetuity for not doing so. A foreigner without residency rights who helps is to be praised, and if he does not help he is to be reprimanded. A slave who helps is to be given his freedom, or if he does not help, let him receive one hundred lashes of the whip from the market commissioners if the assault took place in the market place. If it took ^{881c} place in the city, but outside the market, the resident urban commissioner should administer the punishment. If it happened in some rural area, those in charge of the rural commissioners should see to it. If the bystander is a native-born man, woman or child, they should, in every case, ward off the attack and denounce the

outrageous act. If they fail to do so they are liable by law to the curse of Zeus, the god of kindred and parentage. If any of them are ^{881d} found guilty of assaulting their parents, first let them be exiled from the city to some other region in perpetuity, and excluded from all sacred places. If they ignore the exclusion, the rural commissioners should punish them with whipping, or in any way they please, and if they return to the city they should be condemned to death. If any free-born person eats or drinks or has a similar interaction with such an offender, or even meets up with him and makes physical contact, he should enter no holy place or the marketplace, or anywhere else in the city, before he has been purified, as though he had been involved in an abominable ^{881e} crime. And if he disregards the law and defiles the city illegally, any official who is aware of this and does not prosecute such a person shall, at his audit, face this omission as one of the most serious allegations made against him.⁹⁷ Should a slave strike a free citizen or a foreigner, any bystander should come to their assistance or else be subject to the fine previously specified for their property evaluation. The bystanders shall help the victim to bind the slave, and then turn him over to the wronged party who shall take charge of him, bind him in fetters, whip him as many times as he wishes without detriment to his master, and finally hand him over to that master and rightful owner.

^{882a}

Athenian: So, let the law be that when any slave strikes a free person without being directed to do so by the officials, his owner is to receive him, in bonds, from the person he assaulted, and is not to release him until the slave persuades his victim that he deserves to be released and continue with his life.

^{882b}

Athenian: In all such cases, the same regulations should apply whether women are dealing with women, men with women, or women with men.

BOOK X

884a

Athenian: Now that assaults have been dealt with, a single universal regulation concerning the use of force should be stated as follows. No one is to take or remove what belongs to others, nor should he make use of what belongs to a neighbour without the owner's consent, for all the evils we have described, past, present and to come, derive from such behaviour. Of the remaining causes, the most grievous is unrestrained and outrageous behaviour in the young, and this is most serious when it affects the sacred, and is especially serious in the 885a case of whatever is sacred to the community, or partly so, being common to clans or similar groupings. Second in rank and severity are outrages against private shrines and tombs. Third are outrages against parents, apart from those described earlier. A fourth kind of outrage occurs when someone has so little regard for those in authority that he removes or takes away or makes use of something that belongs to them without their consent. Fifth would be any outrage against the civic entitlement of any individual citizens, calling for legal remedy. A common law applicable to each case should be provided.

885b

Athenian: In the case of temple plundering, by force or subterfuge, we have already stated briefly what should happen to the offenders. We should now say what is to happen in any cases where someone acts outrageously towards the gods, in word or in deed, by what is said or what is done, beginning with a preamble as follows. No one who believes in the gods, as the laws prescribe, has ever deliberately done an impious deed or let loose an unlawful word. If anyone does so it is because one of three things befalls him. Either, as I was saying, he does not really believe in them, or secondly he believes that they exist but do not care about us humans, or thirdly he believes that

they are easily appeased under the influence of sacrifices and prayers.

885c

Clinias: So, what should we do or even say to these people?

Athenian: Good man, let's listen first to what I suspect they would say, mocking us contemptuously.

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: To tease us they would probably say this. "Athenian stranger, Spartan and Cnossian, what you are saying is the truth. Some of us indeed do not believe in any gods at all, while others believe in gods of the kind you are describing. We then deserve the very same ^{885d} treatment that you deserved from the laws, that before issuing harsh threats, you first attempt to persuade us and teach us by providing adequate proofs that the gods exist, and that they are too good to be diverted from the path of justice when beguiled by some gifts of ours. For as matters stand, we hear all this and other ideas of this sort from poets, orators, prophets and priests, of the highest reputation, and from countless others too. And so most of us, ^{885e} rather than following a path where we do nothing unjust, act unjustly and attempt to make amends. From legislators like yourselves then, who claim to be gentle rather than aggressive, we expect to be dealt with first through persuasion. And if you don't do much better than the others in speaking about the existence of the gods, but do better in terms of truth, you may perhaps persuade us. So, if what we are saying sounds reasonable, try to rise to our challenge."

886a

Clinias: It seems easy enough, stranger, to speak truthfully when saying that the gods exist, does it not?

Athenian: How so?

Clinias: First there is the evidence of the earth, sun and stars, and the entire universe, and the beautiful ordering of the seasons, divided into months and years. And then there is the fact that Greeks and non-Greeks alike believe in the existence of gods.

Athenian: Bless you. But I do have a fear of the degenerate folk – although I would never say that I am in awe of them – a fear that they may somehow despise us. Indeed, you don't understand the cause of their disagreement with us, and you believe that lack of control over pleasures and desires is the only thing that impels their souls to a life of impiety.

Clinias: What other cause could there be, stranger, besides this?

Athenian: One which you scarcely understand at all, because you live outside its realm and are unaware of it.

Clinias: What cause are you referring to now?

Athenian: A grievous ignorance that seems to be the height of wisdom.

Clinias: How do you mean?

^{886b}

Athenian: In my country, we have accounts in writing which, as I understand it, are not in existence among yourselves because your civic arrangement is so excellent. These speak of the gods, some in verse, some in prose. The most ancient of them describe how the primal nature of heaven and all else came into being, and, moving on a little from this starting point, describe the birth of the gods and how they treat one another once they have been born. Regardless of whether these accounts are somehow beneficial or detrimental to those who hear them, ^{886c} it is not easy to censure these ancient authorities, and yet I could never bring myself to praise their stories of respect and care for parents, or say that these are beneficial or entirely true.

So we should let go of these ancient tales, bid them farewell, and let them be told in the manner that pleases the gods, while we blame the views of our young folk, and the wise, as the cause of the evils. The arguments of such people proceed as follows. Whenever you and I present proofs for the existence of gods, proposing this very point – that sun, moon, ^{886d} stars and the earth are gods and divinities – the young folk, having been convinced by the wise, are inclined to say that these all consist of earth and stone, and are therefore unable to think about human affairs, and that these proofs of ours have been nicely dressed up in reasoned arguments to make them sound persuasive.

^{886e}

Clinias: The argument you are referring to would be troublesome enough, stranger, even if it was the only one, but nowadays, when there are so very many of them, the difficulty is even greater.

Athenian: What of it? What are we to say? What should we do? Are we to defend ourselves against the impious folk who, when they fall foul of our legislation, accuse us of doing something terrible by enshrining the existence of gods in law? Or should we bid farewell to the issue, in case our preamble becomes longer than the actual laws it is introducing? For our argument ^{887a} would run to considerable length if we were to defer the enactment of suitable laws until we had first presented these people, who are so inclined to impiety, with the reasoned arguments which they say are needed, frightened our accuser away, and made the impious folk detest their impiety.

^{887b}

Clinias: But, stranger, one point has been made many times in the short interval at our disposal: that there is no need at the moment to prefer a short argument over a lengthy one, since as they say no one is chasing after us. So, to be seen choosing the

brief in preference to the best would be comical and undignified. But it is of the utmost importance that our ^{887c} arguments, somehow or other, have a degree of persuasiveness when they maintain that the gods exist, that they are good, and that they revere justice more than any of us humans. Indeed, this formulation would constitute the best and most beautiful preamble for any of our laws. So, without reluctance or impatience, let's deploy any power of persuasion we possess on such issues unstintingly, to expound the arguments adequately as best we can.

^{887c}

Athenian: What you have just said was expressed with such depth of feeling that it seemed to me like a call to prayer. No further delay is allowed then. We must speak. Come on then, how could anyone discourse on the existence of gods without depth of feeling? In fact, it is ^{887d} inevitable that we bear ill-feeling and hatred towards these people who have been, and still are, responsible for our involvement in these arguments, people who don't believe the stories they hear as young children, still at the breast, from their nurses and mothers, tales told in songs of a sort, in a playful or serious spirit, which they also hear directly in prayers during the sacrifices, accompanied by the delightful sights that the young person sees and hears enacted at the sacrifices, beholding their own parents, with the utmost seriousness, offering earnest prayers and supplications on behalf of themselves and their offspring to gods whose ^{887e} existence is undeniable. At the rising of the moon and the sun, and at their setting too, they see and hear the prostrations and adorations of all Greeks and non-Greeks when faced with various misfortunes and successes, not as if there are no gods, but as if they really do exist beyond any grounds for suspicion.

^{887e}

Athenian: But people who view all of this with contempt, without a single adequate argument – as anyone with a

modicum of intelligence would agree – are now compelling us to say ^{888a} what we are saying. So, how might anyone, in mild language, be able to chasten these people and, at the same time, instruct them about the gods, teaching them first and foremost that they exist? But we should take on the task, for there is no use in some among us being maddened by a greed for pleasure, while others are equally maddened by their ill-feeling towards such people. Let our dispassionate preliminary address to those who corrupt their minds in this way proceed, and let's speak to them in mild language with any ill-feeling extinguished, as though we were addressing one person of this sort as follows. "Child, you are young, ^{888b} but as you get older time will transform many of the opinions you now hold into their direct opposites. Wait until then before you sit in judgement on matters of the utmost importance, and the most important is the one that you set at naught – thinking aright about the gods, and so, living, or not living, a good life.

^{888b}

Athenian: "Now, there is one thing I should mention to you at the outset which will never prove false. Neither yourself alone, nor your friends, are the first thinkers to lead the way in holding this opinion about the gods. There are always people, sometimes more, sometimes fewer, ^{888c} who are afflicted with this disease. So I, who have made the acquaintance of lots of them, should inform you that no one who adopts this opinion about the gods when young, the opinion that they don't exist, ever persists into old age still holding to the same belief. But the other two misconceptions about the gods do persist in some cases, although not many: that the gods exist but have no concern for human affairs, or, alternatively, they are indeed concerned, but are easily appeased by sacrifices and prayers. So, if you heed me you will wait until your opinion concerning the gods has become as clear as possible, deliberating ^{888d} as to what the truth of the matter actually is, seeking guidance from

people in general, but especially from the lawgiver. And in the meanwhile, do not dare to show any impiety towards the gods. For whoever is instituting laws for you, now or hereafter, should endeavour to teach you the truth about these matters."

888e

Clinias: What we have said so far, stranger, sounds excellent to us.

Athenian: Entirely so, Megillus and Clinias, but we have unwittingly stumbled upon a wondrous argument.

Clinias: What are you referring to?

Athenian: An argument regarded by most people as the very pinnacle of wisdom.

Clinias: Please clarify.

Athenian: Some people presumably maintain that everything that is coming into being, has come into being or will come into being does so by nature in some cases, by artifice in others, or, again, by chance.

Clinias: Aren't they right to say so?

Athenian: Well, the wise men are likely to be right in what they say, I presume, but let's pursue the matter with them at any rate, and find out what people from that camp actually have in mind.

Clinias: Absolutely.

889a

Athenian: Evidently, they say, the most important and beautiful things are produced by nature and chance, while artifice produces those of lesser importance. Artifice takes the important primary products from nature already created, and then forms and fashions the lesser items, which we all refer to as artificial.

Clinias: What do you mean?

Athenian: I'll explain this more clearly. Fire, water, earth and air all exist by nature and chance, they say, and none of these exist by artifice. And the bodies that then come after these, those of the earth, sun, moon and stars, have come into being through these four entirely soulless entities.

889b

Athenian: They move by chance, each according to its particular power, in such a way that they come together, combining somehow with their own – hot with cold, dry with moist, soft with hard, and so on – for any mixture of opposites that is produced, of necessity, according to chance. In this way, based upon these processes, the whole heaven has come into existence, and everything under heaven, including animals and, indeed, all the plants too. And from these all the seasons have arisen, neither through reason, they say, nor through the agency of some god, nor through artifice, but according to them through nature and chance. Artifice comes afterwards, a later production of these two, itself mortal, born of 889c mortal antecedents. Artifice goes on to generate some playthings, which have not the slightest share in truth, being mere images, just like artifice itself, images that painting generates, music too, and any artifice that assists these. Those artifices that actually give rise to something worthwhile are the ones that lend their own power to collaborate with nature, as happens in the case of medicine, farming and gymnastics. Statesmanship in particular, according to them, involves nature to a small extent, but mostly involves artifice, and so all legislation involves artifice rather than nature, and its propositions are not true.

889d

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: The first point these people make, my friend, is that the gods exist by human artifice, by some legal conventions,

and not by nature. They are different in different places, depending upon what the various peoples agreed among themselves when making their laws.

889e

Athenian: Furthermore, what's good by nature is one thing, and what's good by convention is something else. And what's just is not absolutely just by nature; rather, people are persistently arguing over this and changing their positions, and any changes they make are then authoritative, although they arise from artifice and legal conventions, and not from anything natural. All these, my friends, are the views of men who are wise in the eyes of the young people – prose writers and poets who maintain that supreme justice consists in attaining anything by force. Consequently, various impieties have afflicted our young people, as if gods, like those the law tells us to believe in, don't exist. And so, there are factions because 890a of these, as the clever folk set about attracting people to the life that is correct by nature, the life of ruling over others in truth, and not being in servitude to others by legal convention.

890b

Clinias: What a dreadful argument, stranger, so damaging to young people as citizens of our cities and as individuals in private households.

Athenian: True indeed, Clinias. So what do you think the lawgiver ought to do when such beliefs have been in place for so long? Should he simply stand up in public and issue threats to all and sundry who don't accept the existence of the gods, and don't believe that they are such as the law proclaims that they are, and who adopt the same attitude in relation to what's 890c noble, what's just, and all matters of importance that relate to virtue and vice? Is he to declare that everything must be done in accordance with the beliefs prescribed by the lawgiver in his writings, and whoever does not accept the laws readily should,

in some cases, be put to death, in other cases be beaten, imprisoned or dishonoured, or alternatively suffer poverty or exile? What about persuading the people at the same time as he imposes laws upon them? Is he to avoid adding persuasion to his pronouncements and doing his best to make them gentle?

890d

Clinias: Not at all, stranger. If there happens to be the slightest possibility of any persuasion in relation to such matters, no lawgiver who is worth anything should relent in any way, but he should, as they say, be an out-and-out advocate, supporting the ancient, traditional argument that the gods exist, and any other arguments you have just recounted. And, indeed, he must also defend law itself, and artifice, as being natural or not inferior to nature, since they are products of reason, according to the correct argument which you now seem to me to be propounding, and with which I agree.

890e

Athenian: How eager you are, Clinias! But when addressing lots of people in this way, isn't it difficult to pursue arguments? And don't they take on an inordinate length?

Clinias: What's this, stranger? We were patient with one another when discoursing at such length about drunkenness and about music. Are we to be impatient now on the subject of gods and 891a the like? And, indeed, this argument is surely of great assistance to wise legislation, because legal injunctions, once written down, are completely unalterable, ready to meet any challenge forever. Nor need we worry if they are hard to appreciate at first, since even the slowest learner can come back and consider them over and over. Neither should we be concerned about their length, provided they are beneficial. So, it seems to me that it is both unreasonable and impious for any man not to do his best to support these arguments.

891a

Megillus: I think, stranger, that Clinias has made an excellent point.

891b

Athenian: I couldn't agree more, Megillus, and we should do as he says. Indeed, if such fallacious arguments were not so widely sown in more or less every human heart, there would be no need for counterarguments defending the existence of the gods. But we need them now, so who better than the lawgiver to come to the aid of our most important laws when they are being subverted by evil folk?

Megillus: There's no one better.

891c

Athenian: Well then, speak to me again, Clinias, and you too, for you need to join in the arguments. It is likely that someone who says all this is of the view that fire, water, earth and air, all of which he refers to as 'nature', come first, before everything else, and from these afterwards comes soul. But, in fact, this seems more than just likely, since this is being indicated to us directly by the argument.

Clinias: Very much so.

Athenian: Well, by Zeus, have we discovered a sort of fountain of irrational opinion on the part of all the people who have ever turned a hand to investigations into nature? Let's look at ^{891d} this, scrutinising each argument, for it will make an enormous difference if it can be shown that those who engage in impious arguments, and give the lead to others, are not only employing the arguments badly, but are wide of the mark too. I, for one, think that this is how matters stand.

891d

Clinias: Well said. But where does the error lie? Try to explain this.

Athenian: Well, I shall, it seems, have to deal with unfamiliar arguments.

Clinias: Don't be reluctant, stranger. I do understand that you think we will be straying outside the bounds of legislation if we deal with such arguments, but if it is impossible to agree on the correctness of the descriptions of the gods in our laws, in any other way apart from this, then this, my friend, is the course we must adopt.

891e

Athenian: I should, it seems at this stage, recount a somewhat unusual argument, as follows. According to the arguments that fashion the soul of the impious folk, the first cause of the generation and destruction of all things is said not to come first, but to arise subsequently, and what's subsequent is said to be prior. That's how they fall into error about the actual being of the gods.

Clinias: I do not yet understand you.

892a

Athenian: Soul, my friend – what it's like, and the power it possesses – is a matter about which all but a few are inclined to be in ignorance generally, and especially in relation to its origin. They don't know that soul is among the things that come first, having come into existence before all of the bodies, and more than anything else controls all their changes and transformations. And if this is indeed the case, mustn't anything akin to soul, of necessity, be prior in origin to anything associated with bodies, since soul is older than body?

Clinias: Necessarily.

Athenian: Then opinion, attention, reason, artifice and law would be prior to anything hard or soft, heavy or light. And, indeed, the important primary works and activities would be those born of artifice because they are among the first, while

those that are natural, and nature itself, incorrectly so called, come later and come from artifice and reason.

892b

Clinias: Incorrectly in what sense?

Athenian: By the word 'nature' they intend to describe the generation of things that come first. But if it turns out that soul comes first, rather than fire or air, then soul, having arisen with the things that come first, may be described most correctly as pre-eminently natural. This is how matters stand, provided it can be demonstrated that soul is older than body, but not otherwise.

Clinias: Very true.

Athenian: Shouldn't we set about this very proof next?

Clinias: Indeed.

892c

Athenian: Let's be on our guard, then, against an utterly deceitful argument lest we somehow, in our old age, beguiled by its youthfulness, let it get away from us and turn us into figures of fun, who seem to aim for great things but miss the little ones. So, think about this. Suppose we three needed to cross a river with intense currents, and I happened to be the youngest of us, with a lot of experience of such currents. What if I suggested that I attempt the crossing first by myself, leaving you two behind in safety, so as to test whether the river can be crossed by you two older men or not? And if it turned out to be crossable, I could then, ^{892d} based on my experience, call upon the two of you to make the crossing too, and if it was too deep for you, the danger would be all mine. This would sound like a reasonable suggestion. And, indeed, in this case, the argument we are facing is most intense, and perhaps a little too deep for the strength you possess. So, in case it makes you dizzy and puts you in a spin, with its onslaught of questions you are not

accustomed to answering, and begets ^{892e} a distasteful lack of dignity and decorum, I think I should follow the same procedure myself now. I'll put the questions to myself first, while you two are listening in safety, and then I shall, in turn, answer the questions myself and conduct the entire argument in this way until it has dealt with the subject of soul, and shown that soul is prior to body.

^{893a}

Clinias: We think, stranger, that your suggestion is excellent. Please do as you suggest.

^{893b}

Athenian: Come on, then. If ever there was a time to call for a god's help, now is the time to do so. Let's take it, then, that the gods have been invoked, in all seriousness, to demonstrate their own existence, while we plunge into the argument before us, holding on to this rope for safety. Now, when I am being challenged on such matters with questions of this sort, it seems safest to respond as follows. For instance, when someone asks me, "Stranger, is everything stationary and does nothing move? Or is the situation the exact opposite? Or do ^{893c} some things move while others stay still?", I shall reply that some presumably move, while others stay still. "Now, don't the stationary things stand still, and the moving things move, in a certain place?" "Of course." "And some, presumably, will do this in a single location, others in several." "Do you mean," we shall say, "that objects which can be stationary at their centre are moving in a single location, as happens to circular objects which are said to be stationary, although their circumference is revolving?" "Yes."

^{893d}

Athenian: "And we do understand that in this revolution, carrying around the greatest circle and the smallest one simultaneously, such motion distributes itself to the greater and the lesser, in proportion, being itself both lesser and greater, in

proportion. And so it has become a fount of all wonders as it provides both large and small circles at the same time, with harmonised slowness and swiftness, an outcome which might be regarded as impossible." "Very true."

893e

Athenian: "And when you refer to things moving in several locations, I presume you mean those which move by being borne, constantly changing from one location to another, sometimes having a single centre of support, sometimes more than one, in which case they roll about. Any time they collide with each other, a moving body is disintegrated by a stationary one, whereas moving bodies coming from opposite directions coalesce into a single combination that is midway between the two." "Yes, I agree. This is how matters stand, just as you say."

Athenian: "And, indeed, when combining, they increase in bulk, and when they disintegrate they decrease, provided the established condition of each persists, but if this does not ^{894a} remain, they are dissolved by both processes. So, under what set of circumstances does generation occur in all cases? Obviously it is when a beginning, having taken increase, has arrived at its second stage, and from this arrives at the next, and having reached the third stage becomes perceptible to observers. Everything comes into being by changing and moving in this way. It is really existing only for as long as it persists, and it is completely destroyed whenever it changes to another state."

894b

Athenian: So have we mentioned all movements that can be classified numerically, apart, my friends, from two?

Clinias: Which two?

Athenian: The two for whose sake, good man, almost all of our present enquiry is being conducted.

Clinias: Please clarify.

Athenian: Presumably, it is for the sake of soul?

894c

Clinias: Very much so.

Athenian: Well, let one of the two be the motion that is always able to move other things but is unable to move itself. And of all the various motions, let the other one be the motion that is always able to move itself and other things by combination, disintegration, by increase and its opposite, and by generation and destruction.

Clinias: Let's do so.

Athenian: In that case, we shall place the motion that always moves another and is moved by another ninth. And we shall say that the tenth motion is what moves itself and another, being included in all actions performed or suffered, and is actually called the change and motion of everything that exists.

Clinias: Entirely so.

894d

Athenian: Of the ten motions, then, which should we adjudge most correctly to be the most powerful of all, and most exceptionally effective?

Clinias: We must insist, I presume, that the motion that can move itself is enormously superior, and that all the others come after it.

Athenian: Well said. In that case, must we rectify one or two of the incorrect statements we have made?

Clinias: What are you referring to?

Athenian: What was said about the tenth wasn't really correct.

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: According to the argument, it is first in origin and in potency, and the one after it we hold is second, although we

have just referred to it, oddly, as ninth.

Clinias: What do you mean?

894e

Athenian: Whenever we find something changing something else, and that in turn another and so on, will there ever be a first source of change in such a sequence? How indeed, when this is moved by something else, can this ever be the first of the things that are altered? It is impossible. But when this, having moved itself, changes something else, and that changes another, and thousands and thousands of things are moved in this way, would the source of all the movement of all these be anything other than change in the motion that moved itself?

Clinias: That's very well argued. These points must be conceded.

895a

Athenian: Then let's continue our discussion in this way, and let's reply to ourselves again. Suppose all things had come to a standstill together, as most thinkers of this sort have ventured to suggest, which of the motions we have mentioned would necessarily be the first to arise among them? It would of course be the motion that moves itself, for they will never undergo previous change by something else when there is no previous change among them. So, as the source of all motions, the first to arise among stationary things, and first in rank among things that are in motion, we shall necessarily declare the motion that moves itself ^{895b} to be the oldest and most powerful change of all, while the motion that is altered by something else, and then in turn moves others, comes second.

895b

Clinias: Very true.

Athenian: Well, now that we are at this point in the argument we should answer the following question.

Clinias: Which is?

Athenian: If we were to see this motion in operation in something made of earth or water or fire, either separately or in combination, what condition would we say something of that sort was in?

895c

Clinias: Aren't you asking me whether we should describe something as being alive whenever it moves itself?

Athenian: Yes.

Clinias: Alive, yes of course.

Athenian: What if we see soul in something? Is the situation any different? Mustn't we accept that it is alive?

Clinias: It's no different.

895d

Athenian: Hold there, by Zeus. Wouldn't you be prepared to think of each thing as having three aspects?

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: One is the essence, one is the account of the essence, and one is a name. And, indeed, there are two questions you can ask about everything that exists.

Clinias: What are the two?

Athenian: Sometimes when proffering the name itself we ask for the account, sometimes when presenting the account itself we ask in turn for the name. Anyway, don't we, for our part, wish to convey something like the following?

Clinias: Which is?

895e

Athenian: Among numbers, and everything else too, there is, I presume, something that is divisible into two. The name of this

in the case of number is 'even', and the account is 'number, divisible into two equal parts'.

Clinias: Yes.

Athenian: That's the sort of thing I am referring to. Aren't we speaking of the same thing in either case, whether being asked for the account we respond with the name, or being asked for the name we give the account? By the name 'even' and by the account 'a number that can be divided by two', aren't we describing the same thing?

Clinias: Entirely so.

896a

Athenian: What is the account, then, of that which is designated by the name 'soul'? Have we any other account apart from the one just stated: 'the motion that is able to move itself'?

Clinias: So the same essence, which everyone refers to by the name 'soul', has as its account 'that which moves itself'. Is that your point?

Athenian: Well, that's what I'm saying. So, if this is how matters stand, do we still feel that it has not been satisfactorily proved that soul is the same thing as the first becoming and motion of anything that is, or has been, or will be, and, indeed, of the opposites of all these, since 896b it has been shown to be the cause of change and motion in everything?

896b

Clinias: No, it has been quite adequately proved that soul is the oldest of all, since it has turned out to be the source of motion.

Athenian: Now, mustn't the motion arising in one thing because of another – motion that never gives anything the ability to move itself – come second, or, indeed, as far down the list as you wish to count it, since it is the change in a body that is in reality devoid of soul?

Clinias: Correct.

896c

Athenian: So, our statement would be correct, authoritative, true and certain if we were to assert, as we have done, that soul is prior to body, while body is second and subsequent; that soul is ruling, while body is naturally being ruled.

Clinias: Yes, very true.

Athenian: Now, we agreed in our earlier discussion, as I'm sure you recall, that if soul proved to be older than body, whatever belongs to soul would also be older than whatever belongs to body.

Clinias: Very much so.

896d

Athenian: Then, tendencies, habits, intentions, reasoning, true opinions, attention and memories would have arisen prior to the height, breadth and depth of bodies, if soul is indeed prior to body.

896e

Clinias: Necessarily.

Athenian: Mustn't we necessarily agree next that the cause of whatever is good is soul, and also of whatever is evil, noble, shameful, just, unjust and all their opposites, if we are to insist that soul is indeed the cause of everything?

Clinias: There is no alternative.

Athenian: Then, since soul controls and resides in everything that is moving anywhere, mustn't it also, necessarily, be said to control the heaven?

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: Is there one soul, or more than one? More than one, I shall reply on behalf of both of you. We should propose at least

two – one beneficent, the other capable of producing the opposite effect.

Clinias: Absolutely correct.

897a

Athenian: So be it. Soul impels everything in heaven and earth and ocean, by the motions of itself whose names are intention, consideration, attention, deliberation, opinion both correct and false, delight and tribulation, confidence and fear, hatred and affection. It impels them by these, and by any motions that are akin to these or are primary in their operation. And bringing in their train the motions that are secondary in their operation, and those of bodies, they impel everything to increase or decrease, disperse or combine, and to adopt the related qualities of hot and cold, heavy and light, hard and soft, white and black, bitter and sweet, and all those to which soul has recourse, when with reason – which is ever, rightly, a god to gods – as its helper, it leads everything happily and in the right way, or when it consorts with unreason and produces the very opposite effect in every case. Should we propose that this is how matters stand, or do we still suspect it might be otherwise?

Clinias: Not at all.

897b

Athenian: What kind of soul should we say is in control of heaven and earth and their entire cycle? One that is wise and full of excellence, or one that is possessed of neither? Would you like us to respond as follows?

Clinias: How?

Athenian: If, my friend, we are to state that the entire course and motion of heaven, and of everything it contains, resembles the natural motion, circuit and calculations of reason, and proceeds in a kindred manner, we must of course maintain that the very best soul cares for the entire universe and leads it

along that course.

Clinias: Correct.

897c

Athenian: But if it proceeds in madness and disorder, then the bad soul is in control.

Clinias: That's also correct.

Athenian: What, then, is the nature of this motion of reason? This, my friends, is a difficult question to answer already, with any degree of cogency. And so, it is only right that I take a hand in answering the question, along with you.

Clinias: A good suggestion.

897d

Athenian: Well, in giving our answer let's not, so to speak, look directly at the sun and turn our midday to dark night, acting as though reason could ever be adequately seen and discerned with mortal eyes. Looking at an image of our quest would be a safer way to view it.

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: Of those ten motions, let's adopt the motion which reason resembles as our image. I'll recall this along with you, and then give the answer.

Clinias: An excellent suggestion.

897e

Athenian: Well, of what was said at the time, do we still at least recall that we proposed, in general, that some things are in motion, while others are at rest?

Clinias: Yes.

898a

Athenian: Again, of those that are in motion, some move in one location while others traverse several.

Clinias: So they do.

Athenian: Of these two, the one that moves in one place must always move about some centre, being an imitation of a wheel fashioned on a lathe, and must as far as possible be akin to and resemble the circuit of reason in every respect.

Clinias: What do you mean?

898b

Athenian: If we were to say that reason, and the motion that occurs in one place – both resembling the motions of a fashioned sphere – move of course regularly, in the same way, in the same place, concerned with the same things, in accord with the same things, and a single principle and arrangement, we would never prove ourselves to be inferior craftsmen of noble, verbal images.

Clinias: Quite right.

Athenian: Then again, motion that never occurs in the same way, nor regularly, nor in the same place, that is not concerned with nor in accord with the same things, that does not move with a single motion, order or arrangement, nor on a single principle, would be akin to total unreason.

Clinias: Very true. It would, indeed.

898c

Athenian: At this stage there is no further difficulty in stating categorically that since soul, for us, is what drives everything about, we must declare that the circuit of heaven is necessarily driven about, whilst being cared for and ordered by either the best soul or its opposite.

Clinias: No, stranger. From what has been said just now, it would be unholy to deviate from the statement that what drives these about is one soul, or more than one, possessed of total excellence.

898d

Athenian: You have followed the argument exceedingly well, Clinias. But please attend to the following additional point.

Clinias: Which is?

Athenian: Consider the sun, moon and other stars. If soul does indeed impel everything, would it not also impel each one individually?

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: Then, let's construct arguments concerning one star, and these will prove for us to be applicable to them all.

Clinias: Which one?

898e

Athenian: Although everyone sees the sun's body, no one sees its soul, nor indeed the soul of any other creature's body, alive or dead. But there is great hope that this kind of thing, which cannot be perceived at all by our bodily senses, envelops us, and can be known by reason. By reason alone then, and by thinking, we should understand the following point about this.

Clinias: Which is?

Athenian: Since soul impels the sun, we wouldn't go too far awry in saying that it does so in one of three ways.

Clinias: Which are?

899a

Athenian: Either it resides within this apparent spherical body and conveys this sort of thing everywhere, just as the soul in us carries us everywhere. Or, as some argue, soul, having procured for itself an external body of fire or air, forcibly pushes body with body. Or thirdly, soul itself, devoid of body, exercises its guidance, possessed of other exceedingly wondrous powers.

Clinias: Yes, this must necessarily be so. Soul must impel everything by acting in one of these ways.

899b

Athenian: Better than this, this soul brings light to us all, and whether it does so by having the sun in a chariot, or acts from outside or by some other means, everyone should regard it as a god. Is this so?

Clinias: Yes, unless they had reached an extreme of unreasonableness.

899c

Athenian: Concerning all the stars then, the moon too and the years, months and all the seasons, have we any alternative than to give the very same account? Since soul or souls have turned out to be the causes of all these, being good in respect of every excellence, we shall say that souls are gods, whether they order the entire heaven while present in bodies as living beings, or in some other way. Now, is there anyone, agreeing with all this, who will tolerate the assertion that 'all things are not full of gods'?⁹⁸

Clinias: No, stranger, there is no one so disordered in his thinking as that.

Athenian: Then, Megillus and Clinias, by stating our terms to the person who until now does not believe in gods, let's have done with the matter.

Clinias: What terms?

899d

Athenian: He should either teach us that we are wrong in proposing that soul is the first origin of everything, and in the various conclusions we drew from this, or if he is unable to improve upon our account, he should adopt it and spend the rest of his life believing in the gods. So, let's decide at this stage whether we have done a good job of explaining to those who

don't believe in gods that there are gods, or whether we have fallen short.

Clinias: We have not fallen short in the slightest, stranger.

Athenian: Well, let that be the end of our argument with these people. But we should now admonish those who believe that, although the gods exist, they have no concern for the affairs of us humans. "Good man," we shall say, "as for your belief in gods, it is perhaps some divine kinship that draws you to your common stock, in honour and belief. Now, the fortunes of evil and unjust people in private and in public, are, in truth, unhappy, although they are ^{899e} acclaimed as happy, insistently but erroneously, by public opinion, and so you are led into impiety by their improper celebration in poetry and stories of all sorts. Or again, when you see old men coming to the end of their lives, leaving children and children's children behind, who are held in the highest regard, perhaps you are troubled when you find out, either from others or from personal experience, that amongst their number lots of awful, impious deeds have ^{900a} taken place, and through these very acts they have risen from lowly status to tyrannical power and the highest office. Then, faced with all this, you are obviously reluctant to hold the gods responsible for this sort of thing, because they are your kindred. So, driven by poor reasoning and your inability to criticise the gods, you have ended up in your present predicament ^{900b} where you believe that, although the gods exist, they despise us humans, and don't care about our affairs. Now, so that your current belief does not land you in a worse predicament in terms of impiety, and so that you may be able somehow to banish it by arguments, as it draws nigh, let's attempt to attach the related argument, the one we expounded initially to the total unbelievers, and use this for our present purposes too." You, Clinias and Megillus, should accept the role of answering on the young man's behalf, as you did before. And I, if any

difficulty comes up in the argument, will take over from you, as I did ^{900c} just now, and get you across the river.

^{900c}

Clinias: You are right to say all this. So, do as you suggest, and as best we can we'll do as you bid us.

^{900d}

Athenian: Well, perhaps it would not be too difficult to demonstrate this much at least, that the gods are careful about minor matters, more so, indeed, than about matters of great importance. Indeed, the young man was presumably present at our discussions recently and heard it said that the gods, being good in respect of every excellence, have care for all things, as something that is most appropriate to themselves.

Clinias: Yes, he certainly heard that.

Athenian: Well, next, let us join together and enquire into what is meant by this excellence of theirs, by which we agree that the gods are good. Come on then, to be sound-minded and possessed of reason belongs to excellence, while their opposites belong to evil. Is this what we maintain?

Clinias: We do.

^{900e}

Athenian: And, indeed, that courage belongs to excellence, while cowardice belongs to evil?

Clinias: Very much so.

Athenian: And of these, shall we maintain that the latter are shameful, while the former are noble?

Clinias: We must.

Athenian: And shall we say that the base qualities, if they belong to anyone, belong to ourselves, while the gods have no share, great or small, in anything of this sort?

Clinias: Everyone would agree with this too.

Athenian: What about this? Shall we insist that carelessness, idleness and indulgence constitute excellence of soul? What do you say?

Clinias: No, how could we?

Athenian: So the opposite is the case?

Clinias: Yes.

901a

Athenian: So, do their opposites constitute the opposite condition of soul?

Clinias: Yes, the opposite.

Athenian: In that case, for us, won't any person who is indulgent, careless and idle be someone whom the poet described as "most like a stingless drone"?⁹⁹

Clinias: And he was quite right to say so.

Athenian: Therefore, it must never be said that God has such a disposition as this, a disposition He Himself detests, nor must we allow anyone to attempt to utter such an opinion.

Clinias: No, indeed. How could we?

901b

Athenian: Consider someone who is responsible for acting and really caring for something, but whose mind cares for major issues while neglecting small ones. What grounds could we have for praising such a person without going completely awry? Think of the matter as follows. Doesn't the behaviour of such a person, be he god or man, who acts like this take one of two forms?

Clinias: What are they?

901c

Athenian: Either he is of the view that neglect of the minor matters makes no difference to the whole, or, in spite of the difference it makes, he neglects them out of indifference and indulgence. Or does carelessness arise in any other way? For, presumably, when it is actually impossible to care for all of them, it will not in that case constitute carelessness for things small or great, when someone, be he a god or an ordinary person, neglects what he is unable to care for because it is impossible for him to do so.

Clinias: No, how could that be carelessness?

901d

Athenian: At this stage, then, let the two parties respond to the three of us. They both accept that gods exist, but one says they can be appeased by entreaty, the other that they don't care about little things. You first assert, both of you, that the gods know and see and hear everything, and in any cases where there is knowledge or perception, nothing can escape their notice. Is this what you maintain, or something else?

Clinias: This.

901e

Athenian: Don't they also agree that gods are capable of anything that mortals and immortals are capable of?

Clinias: How could they fail to accept that this is also the case?

Athenian: And the five of us have already agreed that gods are good and excellent.

Clinias: Very much so.

Athenian: In that case, is it not completely impossible for us to accept that they do anything at all out of indifference and indulgence, given that they are as we agree that they are? Indeed, among ourselves at any rate, idleness is born of cowardice, and indifference of idleness and indulgence.

Clinias: Very true.

Athenian: None of the gods, then, show a lack of care out of idleness and indifference, since they are not possessed of cowardice.

Clinias: Correct, indeed.

902a

Athenian: Therefore, we conclude that if they do indeed neglect the small and insignificant details of the All, they would do so either thinking that nothing of this sort should be cared for at all, or, alternatively, we can only conclude that they think the direct opposite.

Clinias: There is no alternative.

Athenian: So, my good and excellent man, what shall we presume your position to be? Are the gods ignorant? And although care is necessary, are they careless out of ignorance of this fact? Or do they know full well that care is necessary, but behave as the basest of us humans are said to behave? They know that another course of action is better, but don't act accordingly because they are somehow overpowered by pleasures or pains.

Clinias: Impossible.

902b

Athenian: Now, don't human affairs have a share in the ensouled nature, and at the same time isn't a human being the most god-fearing of all creatures?

Clinias: So it seems.

Athenian: And we maintain, indeed, that all beings that are mortal are possessions of the gods, and that the whole heaven belongs to them too.

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: At this stage, then, anyone may assert that these issues are small or large in the eyes of the gods. But that doesn't matter, since in neither case would it be proper for those who own us to show a lack of care, when they are supremely caring and good. Yes, and there is something else we should consider besides these.

Clinias: Which is?

902c

Athenian: When it comes to perception and power, aren't these two, by nature, direct opposites of one another in respect of ease and difficulty?

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: It is more difficult, I presume, to see and hear small things than large things, while on the other hand it is easier for everyone to move, control and care for the small and the few, than for their opposites.

Clinias: Very much so.

902d

Athenian: Consider a physician, given the task of treating a body as a whole. If he is willing and able to care for whatever is large, yet neglects the parts and anything small, will he ever have the entire body in good condition?

Clinias: Not at all.

Athenian: No. Nor indeed will steersmen, generals, household managers, nor indeed certain 902e statesmen, nor anyone else of this sort, succeed with the many and great, without the few and the small. In fact, even stonemasons say that without the small stones, the large ones don't sit well.

902e

Clinias: No, how could they?

Athenian: Let us never accuse God then of being inferior to mortal craftsmen, who the better they are at their own proper tasks, great or small, the more precisely and perfectly do they execute them in virtue of a single skill. No. Let us never presume that God, being perfectly wise, ^{903a} willing to care, and able to do so, does not care at all for small things that are easy to care for – just like some idle coward who shirks the work – but does care for the large things.

^{903a}

Clinias: We should never adopt an opinion of this sort about the gods, stranger, for the very notion would be unholy and untrue.

Athenian: I think we have now, already, done very well in arguing against the person who likes to accuse the gods of not demonstrating care.

Clinias: Yes.

^{903b}

Athenian: Well, he has at least accepted, in virtue of the force of our arguments, that what he is saying is incorrect. And yet it seems to me that something further needs to be said to charm him.

Clinias: What sort of thing, my friend?

Athenian: We should persuade the young man, with our arguments, that the one who cares for the All has organised everything with a view to the safety and excellence of the whole, and so each part of the entire, as best it can, experiences and enacts whatever is appropriate. And there are rulers of what's experienced or enacted allocated to these various parts, in each ^{903c} case down to the very smallest, who have attained perfection down to the last detail. Your own part too, tiny as it is, my stubborn friend, is one of these, ever intent upon the All, ever looking thereto. But you have overlooked this very point: that all generation is for the sake of the All, so that a blissful

existence may be secured for the life of the world, which is not created for your sake. No, you are created for its sake. For every physician and skilled craftsman does all his work for the sake of the entire, fashioning the part to serve an overall ^{903d} purpose, the part being for the sake of the whole, rather than the whole for the sake of the part. But you are troubled because you don't recognise that in your own affairs what is best for the All turns out also to be best for you, based on the power of your common origin. And since soul is continually being united with body after body, undergoing multifarious changes of itself or because of another soul, no other role is left for the player of the game except to relocate the character that is becoming better to a better place, and the worse, to ^{903e} a worse place, based on what is appropriate in each case, so that each may be allotted its own proper destiny.

^{903e}

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: In the way that gods may exercise easy care of all things. I think I can describe it in this way. If someone with a constant eye upon the whole, whilst changing the forms of all things, were to fashion fire, for example, into ensouled water, rather than making lots of ^{904a} things from one or one from many, then once they had undergone their first, second or third generation, the variations in the changing arrangement would be unlimited in multiplicity. But as matters stand, the one who cares for the All has a wonderfully easy task.

^{904a}

Clinias: Again, in what way?

Athenian: As follows. Our king has observed that all our actions involve soul, and that among these many are excellent while many too are evil, and that body and soul, once they have ^{904b} come into being, are indestructible but not eternal, just like the gods ordained by law. For there would never be any generation

of living beings if either of these two were destroyed. He realised, too, that any soul that is good is always naturally beneficial, while the evil does ^{904c} harm. So, being aware of all this, He devised a location where each of the parts might lie, to ensure the triumph of excellence and the defeat of evil in the All, in the best and easiest way. In fact, He has devised, in furtherance of this overall purpose, what sort of character, as it develops, should always occupy what sort of position, and in what precise regions it should dwell. The causes of generation of any particular sort he left to the will of each of us. For, in general, the manner of someone's desires in each case, and the nature of his soul, largely determines the sort of person every one of us becomes.

^{904c}

Clinias: Quite likely.

Athenian: So, all things that partake of soul undergo change, having acquired within themselves the cause of change, and as they change they move in accordance with law and the ordinance of fate. The smaller the change of the characters, the less do they proceed on the surface of the region, while with the greater and the more unjust change, they descend into the depths and the so-called 'regions below', which go by the name Hades, and the like, filling people ^{904d} with fears and imaginings whilst alive, or when the body falls. Whenever the soul partakes of evil or excellence to a greater extent, of its own free will or because of the strength of the company it keeps, then, if it has had communion with divine excellence, it becomes pre-eminently divine, and moves to a special, completely holy region, borne to another better place. Under the opposite circumstances, it is transported to the opposite region to live ^{904e} out its life. This is the just decree of the gods who inhabit Olympus.¹⁰⁰ Take note, my impetuous child who believes that the gods care not, that the one who becomes more evil proceeds

to the more evil souls, while the one who becomes better goes to the better, to experience and to enact there, in life and in various deaths, whatever it is appropriate for like to do to like. From this decree of the gods, neither you nor anyone else who has fallen into misfortune ^{905a} shall ever boast of having escaped. For gods who issue decrees have prescribed this one especially above all others, and it should be heeded without reservation. For you will never evade its care, neither by being so small as to dive beneath the depths of the earth, nor by becoming so exalted as to ascend to the very heaven. And you will pay them the proper price, either whilst remaining here, or, indeed, when you have proceeded to Hades, or even ^{905b} when you have been transported to a still more fearsome region than these. You will find that the same argument also applies to those people whom you have seen becoming great from insignificant beginnings, through unholy deeds or the like. You thought they had come out of misery into a blessed life, and that you had discerned in their actions, as though in a mirror, total neglect on the part of the gods, not realising how precisely their contribution fits into the entire. So, my most vigorous friend, this decree must be understood. How could ^{905c} you think otherwise? Someone who does not understand this would never have even an inkling about human life, nor be able to contribute a single word on what makes it happy or miserable. Now, if Clinias here, and the rest of our aged gathering, persuades you of all this, that when it comes to the gods you don't know what you are saying, then thank God for it. But if you require some further argument, then listen, if you are possessed at all of reason, as we address our third opponent. Indeed, I would claim that we have demonstrated ^{905d} to you, and made a fairly good job of it, that the gods exist and care about us humans. But the further proposition, that the gods are susceptible to being placated by wrongdoers provided they are given gifts, should not be accepted by anyone, and should furthermore be refuted by

every possible means.

905d

Clinias: Well said. We should do as you propose.

905e

Athenian: Come on then, by the gods themselves! In what way might they be placated by us, if they could actually be placated? And what would they be, and what sort of beings would they be? They must necessarily be rulers, I presume, since they manage the entire heaven to perfection.

Clinias: Quite so.

Athenian: But what kind of rulers do they resemble? Or, comparing small with great, of all the rulers with whom we could compare them, which are they like? What about comparing them to drivers of competing teams, or steersmen on ships? Or perhaps they might be likened to commanders of armies, or indeed they might be like physicians looking after the ^{906a} body in a war against diseases, or like farmers fearfully anticipating seasons that tend to be difficult for the growth of plants, or even like herdsmen.

906a

Athenian: For since we have agreed among ourselves that the heaven is full of much that is good and also of the opposite, and that there is more of what is not good, the battle, according to us, is undying, and requires wondrous guardians. The gods are our allies, and so are the daimons, and we are, in fact, possessions of the gods and daimons. Injustice and wantonness, accompanied by ignorance, are our undoing, while justice and sound-mindedness, ^{906b} accompanied by wisdom, are our salvation. And these reside in the ensouled powers of the gods, but some trace of such powers may be clearly seen residing here within ourselves. But there are souls dwelling upon earth, and they have acquired unjust gain, akin of course to wild animals. They prostrate themselves before the souls of the guardians, be

they watchdogs, shepherds or supremely exalted masters, persuading them with flattering words and ^{906c} prayerful entreaties that, as the stories of the evildoers recount, they should be allowed to gain excessively at the expense of their fellow men, and suffer no grievous consequences. But we maintain that the transgression I have just named, the excessive gain, is called disease in the case of physical bodies, pestilence in the case of seasons and years, and in the case of cities and political systems this same transgression appears, through verbal transformation, as injustice.

^{906c}

Clinias: Entirely so.

^{906d}

Athenian: So, this argument really amounts to the claim that the gods are always forgiving towards unjust people and wrongdoers, provided they are given a share of the proceeds of the injustice. It's as if wolves were to give a share of their prey to the sheepdogs, who being appeased by the gifts would agree to the ravaging of the flocks. Isn't this, in effect, the argument of those who maintain that the gods can be placated?

Clinias: That's it, indeed.

Athenian: Well then, to which of the guardians mentioned previously could anyone compare the gods without becoming a laughing stock? To steersmen, who, diverted themselves by the ^{906e} "flow and savour"¹⁰¹ of wine, overturn both ship and crew?

^{906e}

Clinias: Not at all.

Athenian: Nor indeed to charioteers, all set for the contest, who are induced by gifts to give up their victory to another team.

Clinias: No, that would be a terrible verbal image to introduce into this argument.

Athenian: Nor to generals either, nor to physicians, farmers or herdsmen, nor indeed to hounds who have been beguiled by wolves.

907a

Clinias: Mind your tongue. How could they?

Athenian: Aren't the gods, all of them, the greatest of all guardians, concerned with what is most important to us?

Clinias: Very much so.

Athenian: Shall we ever maintain then that those who guard the most precious things, and are 907b themselves excellent in their role as guardians, are inferior to dogs and ordinary people, who would never give up what is just because of some gifts offered by unjust men, in an unholy act.

907b

Clinias: Not at all. The notion is intolerable. And of all those who are involved in any form of impiety, anyone who holds this opinion may well be adjudged, quite rightly, as utterly evil, and impious in the extreme.

Athenian: May we assert then that our three propositions have presumably been adequately proved: that the gods exist, that they care about us, and that they are not at all susceptible to being placated when justice is at stake?

Clinias: Undeniably. Yes, we vote with you on these propositions.

907c

Athenian: And, indeed, they have been delivered with some vigour, in our thirst for victory over the evil folk, thirst for victory, my dear Clinias, in case the evil folk might prevail in their arguments, and presume that they are allowed to act as they wish, when they hold so many perverse ideas about the gods. It was our eagerness in the face of these issues that made us speak so assertively. And if we have made the least

contribution towards persuading these men to hate their own character and somehow love its opposite, then we would have done well in delivering our preamble to the laws about impiety.

Clinias: Let us hope so. But if not, the nature of the argument will at least bring no discredit upon the lawgiver.

907d

Athenian: After the preamble, a statement that would act as a correct interpreter of the laws should follow, forewarning the impious folk to change their ways utterly in favour of pious behaviour. For those who disobey, let the law be as follows. If anyone acts impiously in word or deed, whoever comes across this should defend the laws by reporting the matter to the officials. The officials who first find out should bring the offender before the court appointed to judge such matters, according to the laws. And if any official is informed, but fails to act on this, let the official himself be liable to a charge of impiety by anyone who wishes to exact punishment on behalf of the laws. And if someone is convicted, the court is to impose a particular penalty for each particular impious act.

907e

Athenian: Now, although imprisonment is to be imposed in every case, there are to be three prisons in the city: a common one in the area of the market place for most offenders – a secure location for the majority of cases; another close to the meeting place of the Nocturnal Council,¹⁰² is called the house of sound-mindedness; and a third in the middle of the country, ^{908a} in the wildest, most isolated place imaginable, whose very name speaks of punishment. Now, since there are three causes of impiety which we have already described, and from each such cause two kinds of impiety arise, there would be six kinds of people who fall into error concerning divine matters. These need to be distinguished, as they do not deserve an equal or similar penalty. Indeed, a person who does not believe that the

gods exist at all may naturally come to possess a just character, and develop a hatred of evildoers. Due to their detestation of injustice, such people would never attempt to perform such deeds, and would avoid unjust people and love the just.

908b

Athenian: Others, as well as believing that the universe is devoid of gods, are afflicted with a lack of control over pleasures and pains, but are endowed with powerful memories and keen understanding. Now, although they both suffer in common from a lack of belief in the gods, one would do less damage to people in general, and the other, more, for he would be completely outspoken about gods, sacrifices and oaths, and so, by ridiculing others, he ^{908c} would probably make others like himself, unless he meets with justice. The other fellow, although he holds the same views as this one, is referred to as 'gifted', full of trickery and contrivance. From these types we are supplied with prophets aplenty, skilled in all sorts of magic. Sometimes, from their number, tyrants emerge, populists and generals too, and people who devise private mysteries, and the devices of those who are referred to as 'sophists'.

908e

Athenian: There would be many forms of these, two of which require laws to be enacted. The ironical form falls into an error that deserves not one death but two, while the other deserves admonition and imprisonment. In like manner, the belief that the gods do not care about us gives rise to two different kinds of impiety, and the belief that they can be placated to another two.

909a

Athenian: Once these distinctions have been made in this way, those who have acted out of ignorance, without having an evil disposition or character, are to be placed by the judge, as the law decrees, in the house of sound-mindedness for at least five years. During this time, none of the other citizens may associate with them, except members of the Nocturnal Council, who shall

visit them for the purposes of admonition and the salvation of their souls. When their term of imprisonment has run its course, any who are deemed to be sound-minded again may dwell among the sound-minded, but if not, and he is convicted once more of such a crime, let the penalty be death.

909b

Athenian: But there are those who, in addition to their lack of belief in the gods, or their belief that they do not care for us, or can be appeased, have become like wild animals, and who, out of contempt for their fellow men, beguile the souls of many of the living, and claim to beguile the souls of the dead too, and promise to persuade the gods by enchanting them with sacrifices, prayers and hymns, and attempt, for the sake of money, to utterly ruin individuals, entire households and cities. Of these people, whoever is found guilty is to be ^{909c} sentenced by the court to imprisonment in the central prison, according to the law, where no free man shall ever visit them, and they shall receive a food ration from the attendants as decreed by the guardians of the law. When one of them dies, he is to be cast out beyond the borders, unburied. If some free citizen helps to bury him, anyone who wishes is allowed to prosecute him for impiety. If he leaves children behind, fit to be citizens, they are to be ^{909d} cared for by those who look after orphans, just as well as for any other orphans, from the day of their father's conviction.

909d

Athenian: A law should be laid down, applicable in common to all these transgressors, which would make most of them offend less against the gods in word and in deed, and, what's more, become less foolish by forbidding them from dealing in divine matters, in contravention of the law. Indeed, the following law applicable to all cases should be laid down without exception: no one is to have a shrine in his own home. If anyone is moved to perform a sacrifice, let him attend and do so at the public

sacrifices, placing his offerings in ^{909e} the hands of the priests and priestesses who are responsible for their consecration. And he himself shall join in the prayers along with anyone else he wishes to pray with. The reasons for all this are as follows. To establish shrines and gods is no easy task, and to do this sort of thing in the right way requires some serious thought. It is the habit especially of all women, and of those who are sick in any way, and people in peril or deprivation regardless of the cause of the deprivation, and under the opposite circumstances when things go well, ^{910a} to dedicate whatever is to hand at the time, and swear to offer sacrifices and promise to found shrines to gods, to daimons, or to children of gods. And fears caused by apparitions whilst awake, or by dreams and likewise, as they recall numerous visions and are inclined to devise a remedy in each case, incline them to set up altars and shrines, and with these they fill every home and every village, and the open spaces too, and wherever it occurs to such people to place them. For all these reasons, it is necessary to act in accordance with ^{910b} the law we have just described, so that the fraudulent behaviour of the impious people does not extend to these matters too by establishing shrines and altars in private households, believing that they are making the gods agreeable, in secret, through their sacrifices and prayers. They are multiplying their own level of injustice enormously, and so they render themselves, and the better people who trust them, guilty in the eyes of the gods, and the whole city thus reaps the harvest of impieties, and rightly so.

^{910c}

Athenian: God, however, shall not blame the lawgiver. Indeed, let this law be set down: there is to be no possession of shrines in private households, and whoever is caught owning or worshipping at any shrines, except the public ones, regardless of whether the owner is a man or a woman, provided their wrongdoing is not enormously unholy and whoever notices this

is to inform the guardians of the law, who in turn are to order that the private shrines be removed to the public areas, and if the owners do not co-operate, they are to impose penalties until the shrines are removed. But if someone is found to be acting impiously, not the trivial ^{910d} impieties of children but the serious impieties of mature adults, either by setting up shrines in private or while performing public sacrifices to any god whatsoever, he is to be sentenced to death for performing sacrifices when he is not in a pure state. The guardians of the law, having decided whether the offence is childish or not, shall bring the offenders before the court, and, accordingly, impose the penalty upon them, appropriate to their impiety.

BOOK XI

^{913a}

Athenian: What is needed after all this is proper regulation of our dealings with one another. The simple rule, I believe, is this: as far as possible, no one should touch my personal property, nor indeed disturb it in the slightest unless he has my full consent. And I, if I have any sense, would act on the same basis in relation to the property of others. Let us speak, in the first place, of treasure which someone who is not an ancestor of mine has set aside as a ^{913b} hoard for himself and his own people. I must never pray to the gods that I may discover such treasure, nor if I find it should I disturb it, nor indeed should I take advice from the so-called prophets who are certain to advise me to "take up what has been deposited in the earth". For I would never gain as much benefit in terms of wealth by taking it up as I would increase the store of my soul's virtue and justice by letting it lie. For by acquiring one possession instead of another, the better one in my better part, I prefer to acquire justice in my ^{913c} soul rather than riches in my estate. This is one of the many cases where it is well said that "the immovable is not to be moved". And we should also heed the stories that are told about

these matters whereby nothing of this sort is advantageous to future generations. And whoever pays no heed to children disregards the one who enacted the law, and takes up, without the permission of the person who put it there, what neither himself nor his ancestors put down. He thus subverts the most sublime of all laws, the simplest one, enacted by a truly ^{913d} noble man,¹⁰³ which states, "don't take up what you have not put down." But what should happen to someone who despises these two lawgivers¹⁰⁴ and takes up what he himself has not put down, a treasure of some significance, often quite enormous? What the gods will do to him, God knows, but the first person to become aware of the offence is to report it. If this sort of thing happens in the city, he informs the city police, or the market police if it ^{914a} happens in a city marketplace, and if it occurs elsewhere in the country, the rural police and those in charge of them are to be informed. Once they have been informed, the city is to send a delegation to Delphi, and whatever the god ordains in relation to the treasure or the person who disturbed it is to be enacted by the city in subservience of the pronouncements of the god. If the person who disclosed the offence be a free-born citizen, let him be famed for his excellence, or indeed for his depravity if he does not disclose the offence. If a slave discloses the crime, it would be right for the city to give him his freedom, having compensated his master, but he should be sentenced to death for failure to do so.

^{914b}

Athenian: Following on from this, there would be a related rule concerning major and minor matters alike. If someone leaves behind anything of his own, anywhere, either intentionally or unintentionally, whoever comes across the item should let it lie in the belief that anything of this sort is under the protection of the goddess of the wayside, the goddess to whom such items are consecrated by the law. If anyone, acting contrary to these precepts, takes the items up and takes them home, and the

offender be a slave and the items of little value, ^{914c} whoever comes across him shall, if over thirty years of age, whip the fellow thoroughly. If the offender be a free-born citizen, he is to be regarded as someone unworthy of freedom who has no involvement with the laws, and he should pay the owner ten times the value of whatever goods he disturbed. If one person accuses another of being in possession of some of his property and the accused admits that he has the property but denies that it belongs to the accuser, then, if the property be legally registered with the officials, the possessor is to be called before the court and he is to produce the item there. Once it is on display, if it has ^{914d} been duly recorded in the register and it is obvious which of the disputants it belongs to, let him take it and depart. If it belongs to someone else who is not present, whoever provides the most acceptable surety should take it away, by his legitimate right of removal on behalf of the absent person, in order to return the item to that person. If the disputed item has not been registered with the officials, let it remain with three of the oldest officials until the case is decided. And if the pledged item be a beast, whoever loses the relevant case shall compensate the officials for its upkeep. The officials shall decide the case within three days.

^{914e}

Athenian: Anyone may handle his own slave as he pleases, provided he is sensible, using him as he wishes for any legitimate purposes. And he may also handle a runaway slave for safekeeping on behalf of someone else from among his own family or friends. If someone is being led away as a slave and someone else removes him to freedom, whoever is leading him should let him go, while the person removing him should put three acceptable sureties in place and remove him to freedom on these terms, but not otherwise. And if anyone ^{915a} removes the person contrary to these conditions, he may be charged with assault, and, on conviction, shall pay double the registered

damages to the deprived party. One may also lay hands upon a freed slave if he does not attend to those who freed him or does so inadequately. The attention involves visiting the home of those who freed him three times a month, and offering to do whatever needs to be done, provided it is fair and within his capacity. When it comes to marriage he should do whatever his former master consents to. He is not allowed to become more wealthy than the man who freed him, and any excess is ^{915b} to belong to the former master. The freed slave may not remain in the country for more than twenty years. Rather, just like the other foreigners, he too must depart, taking all of his own property unless he persuades the officials and the person who freed him, to let him stay. If the freed slave, or indeed any other foreigners, come to have more wealth than the size of the third property valuation, let them depart, taking their own property, within thirty days of the day on which this threshold is reached. And in this case no application to remain is to be granted by the officials. If some foreigner disobeys these precepts and is brought to ^{915c} court and convicted, let him be put to death and let all his wealth become public property. These cases are to be tried before the tribal courts unless the charges against one another have been resolved previously before their neighbours or specially selected jurors. If anyone claims another person's animal as his own, or some other item of the person's property, the person who has the item should refer the matter to the person who, as its deserving and rightful owner, sold it to him or gave it to him or conveyed it to him in some other legitimate way. In the case of a citizen, or a foreigner residing in the city, this ^{915d} should happen within thirty days, or in the case of a foreign delivery, five months, the middle month of which is to include the summer solstice. Whatever one citizen exchanges with another through sale or purchase is to be handed over in the location specified for each item in the marketplace, and nowhere else. It must be paid for there and then, upon receipt,

and ^{915e} no purchase or sale is to be conducted on credit. This is the process of exchange. If someone carries out any exchange at all with someone else, in a different way or in a different place, because he trusts the person he is dealing with, let him do so on the understanding that no legal redress is available in relation to anything that is not sold in conformity with the regulations just described. In the case of private associations, anyone who wishes may subscribe as a friend to fellow friends, but if any dispute arises about the subscription payment, they must proceed on the basis that no legal redress is to be available in relation to these matters. Whoever sells something and receives a price of more than fifty drachmas must ^{916a} remain in the city for ten days, and the purchaser is to be told where the vendor lives because of the accusations that tend to be made in relation to such transactions and on account of legal rights to return goods. Let the legal rights to return goods or not be as follows. If someone sells a slave suffering from consumption or stone or strangury or the so-called 'sacred disease'¹⁰⁵ or some other disease, physical or mental, that goes unnoticed by most people and is long-lasting and hard to cure, then if the sale is to a physician or to a trainer, let there be ^{916b} no right of return in such circumstances, nor if the purchaser was told the truth at the time of the sale. If such a practitioner makes such a sale to an ordinary person, the purchaser has a right of return for six months except in the case of the sacred disease, where he is allowed to return the sick slave within twelve months. The case is to be judged by a panel of physicians proposed and selected jointly by the two parties, and, on conviction, a seller shall pay ^{916c} double the selling price. If one private citizen sells to another, let there be a right of return and a procedure for trial as previously described, and let a vendor, on conviction, pay the mere selling price. If someone sells a murderer and both parties know this, let there be no right of return such a purchase. But if the buyer did not know, then he has a right of return once he

becomes aware of the fact. The case is to be decided before five of the youngest guardians of the law, and if it is decided that the seller knew about the murder, let him purify ^{916d} the purchaser's household according to the prescription of the interpreters of the divine law, and pay him three times the selling price. When someone exchanges money in return for money or for anything else, animate or inanimate, then in conformity with the law, what is given or received must not be counterfeit in any way. And as we did with the other laws, let us also allow a prelude concerning this general malaise. Everyone needs to appreciate that counterfeiting, lying and deception, ^{916e} constitute a single kind, which most people are inclined, mistakenly, to regard as the right thing to do on many occasions, once the action is opportune, but the how and the when of what is opportune they leave unspecified and undefined. For this precept they themselves pay a high price and they impose the same upon others. But the lawgiver is not allowed to leave this matter undefined; rather, upper or lower limits should always be spelled out, and indeed these should be specified now. No one, calling upon the gods, is to engage in any ^{917a} falsehood, deceit, or counterfeiting either in word or in deed, if he is to avoid being detested by the gods as someone who swears false oaths, with no regard for the gods, or, less so, as someone who lies to those who are his own superiors. Now, the better people are superiors of the worse, the older are generally superiors of the younger, and so, parents are superiors of children, men of women and children, and rulers of those who are ruled. It would be appropriate for everyone to revere all these people, those who hold any position of authority, and especially those who hold office in the state, and this is what our present argument has ^{917b} been dealing with. For anyone who engages in counterfeiting of the commodities of the market place is lying and deceiving, and, calling upon the gods, he swears an oath in the face of the market police and their protections, showing

neither reverence for his fellow man, nor piety towards the gods. It is certainly a good practice not to have free recourse to ^{917c} the names of the gods, and hold to the purity and scrupulousness that most of us generally and consistently adhere to in anything concerning them. If this is not heeded, the law is as follows. Anyone selling anything in the marketplace should never state two prices for what he is selling; he is simply to state one price, and if he does not get this price, it is only right that he take the goods away again and not increase or decrease the price on the same day; and he is to refrain from singing the praises of wares, and swearing oaths about them. If anyone disobeys these regulations, any townsman over thirty years of age who comes across ^{917d} him is to punish the oath taker by beating him, with impunity, but if he ignores the offence and disregards this requirement, he is liable to censure for betraying the laws. Someone who sells anything counterfeit and is not amenable to influence by our present argument is to be challenged before the officials by whatever knowledgeable person comes across him and is able to mount a challenge, and if he be a slave or a resident foreigner, let him keep the counterfeit item. A citizen who does not challenge him is to be proclaimed a criminal for defrauding the gods, but if he does issue a challenge, he is to dedicate the item to the ^{917e} gods of the market place. Whoever is caught selling something of this sort, as well as being deprived of the counterfeit item, is to be scourged with one lash for each drachma of the selling price, and a herald is to proclaim in the market place the reason why the fellow is about to be beaten. The market police and the guardians of the law, having found out about the various counterfeits and malpractices from those who have the relevant experience of each craft, are to write up the details of what a seller should and should not do, and inscribe this on a tablet placed before the office of the market police as clear legal information for those doing business in the

market place. The duties of the market police have been sufficiently explained previously, but if anything more is thought necessary, they are to confer with the guardians of the law, write down the required details, and place on a tablet in front of the office of the city police the initial and subsequent regulations governing their responsibility.

918a

Athenian: After counterfeit activities, the business of retailing trade follows directly. We shall first offer advice and argument concerning this matter as a whole, and then put a law in place. Indeed, the natural purpose for which there is retailing within a city is not to do harm, but the very opposite. For how could someone who brings about a balanced and measured distribution of goods, which had previously been unbalanced and out of measure, be anything but a benefactor? The power of money, we must declare, brings this about, and we 918b should say that this is also the role assigned to the merchant. And, indeed, the hireling, the innkeeper and others, some well regarded, some held in low esteem, all have the ability to provide satisfaction of everyone's needs and an even distribution of wealth. So, why exactly is this regarded as ignoble and unseemly, and why has it come to be disparaged? Let us 918c look at this so that we provide a legal remedy, for parts of it at least, if not for all of it. This, it seems, is no ordinary undertaking and requires a significant degree of excellence.

918c

Clinias: How so?

918d

Athenian: Dear Clinias, some small section of humanity, naturally few in number, trained to the utmost, is able to hold fast to measure whenever they are afflicted by various needs and desires, and are sober when they are in a position to acquire great wealth, choosing measure in preference to excess. The broad mass of humanity is in the opposite situation to these

people: when they have needs they know no bounds, and when they are able to make measured gains, they choose greed instead. That is why all those involved in retailing, merchant trading and inn-keeping are disparaged and subject to shameful criticism. But there ^{918e} is something which I pray may never happen and surely never will, something which sounds ridiculous and which I propose to speak of nevertheless. What if someone were to compel the very best men, for a time, to do inn-keeping or retailing or engage in some other activity of that sort, or indeed compel the women by force of necessity to get involved in some such occupation? We would then realise that each of these occupations is a welcome friend, and provided they are conducted on incorruptible principles, all such occupations are to be respected as a mother and a nurse. But nowadays someone sets up his dwelling in an isolated ^{919a} place, a long way from anywhere, in order to conduct retail trade. There he receives into his welcoming abode the distressed travellers and refugees from fierce and violent storms, providing them with quiet shelter or cool respite from extreme heat. But then, rather than receiving them as companions and providing them with friendly hospitality as well as entertainment, he treats them as captured enemies to be released in return for an enormous, unjust ^{919b} and heinous ransom. These transgressions and the like, in all occupations of this sort, provide proper grounds for criticism of this care for the distressed. For these the lawgiver must consistently find a remedy. Indeed, it has rightly been said of old that it is hard to fight against two foes and from opposite sides, as is the case with various diseases and in many other situations too. And now, in particular, our battle against these transgressions is a battle ^{919c} against twin foes, poverty and wealth. One corrupts the soul of humanity with luxury, while the other drives it to shamelessness out of sheer pain. What remedy might there be for this disease in a city possessed of reason? The remedy is,

firstly, to make the least possible use of retailers as a class; secondly, to assign the role to those whose corruption would not constitute a major outrage for the city; and thirdly, some means must be found whereby those ^{919d} involved in these roles do not end up too easily with a character possessed of unchecked shamelessness and meanness of soul. After these preliminaries, by good fortune we may have a law as follows. Of the Magnesians whom the god is restoring and settling anew, none of the 5,040 landholders who belong to the associated households shall become a retailer, either intentionally or under compulsion, nor a trader either, nor shall he provide a service of any kind to private individuals who do not render an equal service to himself, ^{919e} except to his father and mother, to prior generations, and to all his elders, free citizens whom he freely serves. It is not easy to determine precisely by law what constitutes free service and its opposite, so this should be decided by those who have acquired a peerless reputation for their detestation of the one and their love of the other. Whoever gets involved, by any device, in retailing that is not free, may be prosecuted by anyone who wishes before those with the foremost reputation for excellence. And if he is adjudged to have sullied his own ancestral hearth by an unworthy occupation, he is to be imprisoned for one year to ^{920a} discourage such activity. If he repeats the offence he is to be imprisoned for two years, and the term of imprisonment is to be doubled for each repetition thereafter. There is to be a second law whereby the person who intends to engage in retailing must be a resident alien or a foreigner, and thirdly, let there be a third law to ensure that such a person, dwelling among us in our city shall be as good as possible, or evil to the least possible extent. To this end, the guardians of the law should bear in mind that they are guardians not only of those people whom it is easy to guard from lawlessness and evil ways, of those who have been well ^{920b} educated by their family and upbringing;

rather they should exercise even more guardianship of those who are not like this and engage in activities which have a strong tendency to turn people to evil ways. Accordingly, retailing, which is quite extensive, and the numerous debasing activities it includes, those whose continuance in the city is regarded as absolutely necessary, shall be the subject of a meeting of the guardians of the law with those who are ^{920c} experienced in the particulars of the relevant area of retailing. This is similar to the ^{920d} procedure prescribed earlier in the case of counterfeiting – a closely related matter. When they meet, they are to see what rate of income and expenditure makes a moderate profit for the retailer, and the resulting rates of income and expenditure are to be set down in writing and enforced by the police of the market, the city and the country. In this way, retailing might be of benefit to everyone, while doing the least harm to those who practise it in our cities.

^{920e}

Athenian: If someone agrees to a contract and fails to act in accordance with the agreement, except in cases where the laws or a decree prevent its fulfilment, or an agreement is made under unfair compulsion or force, or when someone is hindered, despite his intentions, by unforeseen circumstances, let there be for all other unfulfilled agreements a trial before the tribal courts, unless they are able to settle the matter in advance before arbitrators or their neighbours. The class of craftsmen who help in providing for our daily life with their skills are sacred to Hephaestus and Athena, while others who safeguard the products of the craftsmen using different, defensive skills are sacred to Ares and Athena, and it is only right that these people as a class are also sacred to these gods. Indeed, they all continuously look after the country and its people, one group by taking charge of military conflicts, while the others produce, for a wage, various tools and wares. And out of reverence for their ancestral gods, it would be improper for

such people to be deceitful in respect of such activities. So, if any craftsman malevolently fails to complete his work within a specified time because he does not revere the god who provides his livelihood, and believes, blindly, that the god is forgiving because of their kinship, he shall firstly pay a penalty to the god, and secondly an associated law is to be put in place.

921a

Athenian: He is to owe the value of the works which were the subject of his falsehood towards his employer, and he must do the work again, from the beginning, within the specified time, free of charge. The law will advise the contractor undertaking the work in the same way as it directed the vendors. They were told not to take advantage by setting a higher price, but to ask simply for what the item is worth, and the contractor is told to do the same since a craftsman is aware of the real value. So, in a city of the free, the craftsman should never use his skill, which, by nature, is pure and free of deception, to impose craftily upon private individuals, and there is to be a legal remedy available for the victim against the wrongdoer in such cases.

921b

Athenian: If, on the other hand, someone engages a craftsman and does not pay him his due wages according to their legal agreement – all for love of petty profit, dishonouring Zeus, protector of the city, and Athena, and their joint role in civic affairs – he thereby weakens our vital communal spirit. So, let there be a law to preserve this divinely ordained civic bond, as follows.

921c

Athenian: Someone who has received goods and has not paid the contractor within the agreed time shall be liable for double the amount. And if a year should elapse, although all other money lending is to be interest-free, this person shall pay one obol on the drachma for each month of arrears.¹⁰⁶ Actions in such cases are to be heard before the tribal courts.

921d

Athenian: As we have dealt with craftsmen in general, it is only right to speak in passing of the craftsmen responsible for our safety in war, such as generals and those possessed of skills in the area. Whatever applies to these also applies to those who are craftsmen of a different sort. So if any of them undertakes public service, either as a volunteer or as a conscript, and he does a good job, the law will never tire in its praise of the citizen who recompenses him with the soldiers' wages, namely honour. But if he receives some noble military service but offers no recompense, the law will censure him.

921e

Athenian: So, let there be a law associated with our praise of these people which gives advice to the broad mass of citizens rather than 922a compelling them. They are to honour, in second place, those good men who act as saviours of the entire city, either by their courageous deeds or military exploits, for the greatest respect is due to those in the first rank, those who are pre-eminently capable of honouring the enactments of the good lawgivers.

922b

Athenian: We have now, more or less, made regulations concerning the most important contracts that people enter into, except for those relating to orphans and the care of orphans by their guardians. So after all we have said so far, we need somehow or other to regulate these matters too. The origins of all these contracts lie in the desires of those who are about to die to put their affairs in order and the vagaries of those who make no such arrangements at all. And I used the word 'need', Clinias, because I had noted the complexity and difficulty of such situations. We cannot leave this area unregulated either. Indeed, if unquestioned 922c authority were granted to any will that anyone makes, regardless of his disposition as his life draws to a close, people might make

arrangements that were self-contradictory, or contrary to the laws, or to the ways of their fellow men, or to their own ways prior to the making of their will. For most of us, when we believe that our end is nigh, become unreasonable or broken in spirit.

922c

Clinias: What of it, stranger?

Athenian: A person who is about to die presents a challenge and is gripped by an alarming notion, difficult for the lawgiver to deal with.

Clinias: In what way?

922d

Athenian: In seeking supreme authority over everything, he is inclined to speak in anger.

Clinias: What sort of things does he say?

Athenian: Ye Gods! He will say, "What a terrible thing it is if I am not allowed to bestow or withhold my own property from whomsoever I please, giving more to one and less to another who has proven to be good to me, or not so good, when sufficiently tested in sickness, old age, and the various other circumstances of life."

Clinias: Yes, stranger, but don't you think they have a point?

922e

Athenian: I think that the ancient lawgivers were too soft, Clinias, and passed laws based upon a narrow view of human affairs and a partial understanding.

Clinias: How so?

Athenian: For fear of this argument, my good man, they enacted the law allowing anyone to make ^{923a}any arrangement he pleases in relation to his own property, without restriction. But you and I will respond more suitably to those in your city

who are about to die. "Friends," we shall say, "veritable creatures of a day, it is difficult for you now to know your own possessions, and also, in accord with the Delphic maxim, to know your own selves too. So I, as your lawgiver, decree that neither yourselves nor this property belongs to you, but to your kinfolk as a whole that was and will be hereafter, and, even more so, that all of your kindred and ^{923b} its property belong to the city. And this being the case, I shall not willingly give my consent if someone persuades you, when you are distressed by sickness or old age, to make a will that is contrary to what's best by stealing upon you with flatteries. I shall legislate from the overall perspective of what is best for the city and the people, justly assigning less importance to a single individual. So you should proceed with us in tranquillity and goodwill, ^{923c} continuing along this journey, the natural course of mankind. Everything else of yours will be looked after by ourselves, exercising the very best care, without any exceptions or omissions. These shall be our consolations and preliminaries, Clinias, addressed to the living and to those who are about to die, and let the law be as follows: Whoever is making a will disposing of his own property should, if he is the father of children, first indicate which of his sons he deems worthy to be his heir, and he should also include the name of any of his ^{923d} other children whom he gives in adoption to someone else. If there is, besides, any other son who has not been adopted as heir to some holding who hopes to be sent legally to a colony, the father is allowed to give him as much as he wishes from the rest of his wealth, apart from the family holding and its associated provision. If there are a number of them, the father may allocate to them anything he owns, over and above the holding, in any proportion he wishes. Nothing is to be allocated to a son who already owns a house, and likewise he shall make no allocation to a daughter who is already betrothed to a man, but he is ^{923e} to make an allocation if she is not betrothed. If it

turns out, after the will has been made, that a son or a daughter has come into possession of a local holding, they are to leave it in the hands of the heir of the person who made the will. If there is no male issue but there is female issue, the testator is to bequeath a man as husband to any daughter he chooses, and as a son to himself as his designated heir. In case a son, begotten or adopted, dies as a child before he can attain manhood, a provision is to be included to meet such a situation whereby ^{924a} the will is to specify the child who is to succeed this son, with better fortune. If someone completely childless makes a will, he may set aside one tenth of his excess wealth, and if he wishes to gift it to anyone, he may do so, having given everything else over to the adopted heir whom he shall make his son, legally, with integrity on one side and acceptance on the other. When the children require guardians and the person dies having made a will specifying whom he wants as guardians and their number, and they willingly agree to act in that capacity, the choice of guardians, documented in this way, shall be final. If someone dies without having made any will at all, or the selection of guardians is omitted, the official guardians are to be the closest relatives on the father's and mother's side, two from each side, plus one friend of the deceased person, and these are to be appointed by the guardians ^{924b} of the law for any orphan who needs them. All aspects of guardianship and orphans should always be looked after by fifteen guardians of the law, the most senior of all, who are to divide themselves into three groups according to their age. Three are to act for one year, and another three for the next, until five periods of office have completed their cycle, and as far as possible there are to be no exceptions to this procedure. If anyone dies without having made a will at all, and he leaves children requiring guardians, his needy children shall avail themselves of these same laws. If a man meets ^{924c} with an unexpected misfortune, leaving daughters behind him, he must be forgiving towards the

lawgiver who arranges the betrothal of the daughters if he observes only two of three important precepts – namely, close family kinship and the preservation of the family holding – and neglects the third one which a father would look to, which is to find, by assessing the entire citizen body, someone suited in character and manners as a son to himself and a bridegroom to his daughter. This the lawgiver abandons as an impossible task. Let's do our best, then, to have the following law enacted in relation to such matters. If someone with no will dies, leaving daughters behind, a brother of the deceased, having ^{924d} the same father or the same mother, who does not have a holding, shall take responsibility for the daughter and the holding of the deceased. If there is no brother but there is a brother's child, the same arrangement applies, provided they are the right age for one another. If neither of these is available but there is a sister's child, then the same arrangement applies. The fourth option is a father's brother, fifth is his child, and sixth the offspring of his father's sister. And so, the line always proceeds, based upon proximity of kinship, through brothers, brothers' children, first the males then the females, in a single family, whenever someone ^{924e} leaves female children behind. A judge is to decide, by inspection, upon the match or mismatch of their ages for marriage, by looking at the males naked and the females naked from ^{925a} the waist up. If there is a deficit of relatives within the family as far as brothers' grandchildren on the one hand, or grandfather's children on the other, then whichever willing citizen the girl with her guardians willingly chooses from among the citizen body shall become the heir of the deceased and the bridegroom of his daughter.

^{925b}

Athenian: But circumstances vary, and there may come a time when there are even fewer eligible males in the city itself. If a young lady, at a loss for a husband locally, sees someone who had been previously sent to a colony and has in mind that the

man become heir to her father's property, then if he is related to her he may proceed to the holding in accordance with the direction of the law. If he is from outside her family, and no one in the city is her near relative, then based upon the selection of the deceased's daughter and her guardians, ^{925c} he is authorised to marry her and return home to take over the holding of the intestate man. If someone dies without issue, male or female, and without a will, let the law in such a situation be, in general, the same as the previous one, and let a male and female family member occupy the deserted home as consorts, so to speak, in each case, and let their claim to the ^{925d} lot be ratified. The order of succession shall be sister first, brother's daughter second, a sister's child third, a father's sister fourth, the daughter of a father's brother fifth, and the daughter of a father's sister sixth. These shall reside with the male kinsmen according to their closeness of kinship and their right as decreed in our earlier legislation. Now, we should not overlook the burden associated with laws of this sort since they sometimes harshly direct a relative of the deceased to marry a close relation, while seeming to take no ^{925e} account of countless impediments which make someone reluctant to comply with such commands, and prefer to suffer any other fate at all. This happens when there are physical or mental diseases or defects in either of the parties to the proposed marriage. The lawgiver might seem to show no regard for these factors, but this is not the case. So, let there be a statement in the interests of the lawgiver and whoever is subject to the law, a sort of general preamble, asking those who are given directions to be forgiving towards the lawgiver, because in his care for public interests he may not always be able, at the same time, to man- ^{926a} age the particular difficulties of private individuals. And those who are subject to the laws should, in turn, be forgiven if they are sometimes naturally unable to fulfil the directions of the lawgiver, directions he gave in ignorance of those difficulties.

926a

Clinias: Well, stranger, what would be the most reasonable course of action under such circumstances?

Athenian: Arbitrators need to be selected, Clinias, for these laws, and for those who are subject to them.

Clinias: How do you mean?

926b

Athenian: Sometimes a nephew with a rich father might be unwilling to take his uncle's daughter in marriage, giving himself airs, with his mind set upon a more significant match. There are times, too, when the lawgiver gives a direction that presents enormous difficulty, and a person is compelled to disobey the law because, for instance, he is being forced to marry into a family where there is madness or various other terrible difficulties of body or soul which make life unbearable. So let our statement on the matters be a law, as follows. If any-
926c one finds fault with the laws in place concerning a will or anything else at all, especially if it concerns marriages, and insists that the lawgiver himself, were he alive and present, would never have insisted upon such a course of action and forced the couple to marry, as is now proposed, while some relative or guardian, on the other hand, says otherwise, then we declare that the lawgiver has left the fifteen guardians of the law as arbitrators and fathers to the orphans, male and female, and the disputants are to go to these people and submit to 926d their judgement, and their pronouncements are to be final. If someone believes that too much power has been entrusted to these guardians of the law, he may take them to court, the court of selected judges, and submit to their judgement regarding the points in dispute. If he loses the case, he must accept censure and disgrace from the lawgiver, a penalty more grievous to a man of reason than any large fine.

926e

Athenian: So the orphaned children would now undergo a kind of second birth. How they are all to be reared and educated after their first birth has already been described. After their second birth, being bereft of parents, some means must be devised by which their orphan plight will give the least cause for pity at the misfortune of those who have been orphaned. Firstly, we say that they are to be given, by law, guardians of the law in place of their natural fathers, and every bit as good, and, what is more, we direct these people to look after them, year by year, as if they were their own. And we now add a preamble on the rearing of orphans, appropriate to these people themselves and to the guardians.

927a

Athenian: I now see that there was something opportune in what we mentioned earlier about the souls of the departed, even after death, possessing a certain power whereby they still care about human affairs. Although the accounts dealing with this are true, they are quite lengthy, but we should believe the general tradition concerning these matters, varied and most ancient as they are. What is more, we should also believe the lawgivers who maintain that this is the case, unless 927b we see them as utter fools. If this is the natural state of affairs, there should be fear, first and foremost, of the gods above, who are aware of the loneliness of orphans; secondly of the souls of the departed, which naturally care greatly for their own offspring, honour those who are kind to them and have no respect for those who are unkind. Finally, there should be fear of those who are still alive but well advanced in years and much respected. Where a city flourishes and has good laws, our children's children live happily in tender love for 927c such people who have sharp eyes and keen ears for these matters and are kind to those who act justly in this area, while they get exceedingly angry with those who mistreat a lonely orphan whom they regard as a mighty and sacred responsibility. A guardian or official with any

sense should pay attention to all these people and take care of the upbringing and education of orphans as if he were providing sustenance to himself and his own kindred, and ^{927d} do his very best to benefit them in every possible way. Whoever heeds the message of our preamble to the law and does not mistreat a single orphan shall not unleash the unbridled wrath of the lawgiver against such crimes, but whoever heeds it not and wrongs someone who has no father or mother, shall pay twice the total compensation payable by a person who behaves badly towards someone with two living parents.

^{927e}

Athenian: When it comes to general legislation for guardians in relation to orphans, and for officials in relation to their responsibility for guardians, if, on the one hand, they had never come across a model for the rearing of free-born children themselves in rearing their own children and looking after their own property, and if they did not have laws setting out the relevant details properly, it would make sense to have a law of guardianship framed specifically for this purpose, distinguishing the life of orphans from that of others by certain specific features. But nowadays, among ourselves, although the status of an orphan is not much ^{928a} different in all these respects from someone under paternal care, they do tend to differ greatly in terms of the level of respect they are shown and the level of care they bestow. For this very reason our law has been quite serious about encouragement and threats in its legislation concerning orphans. But a threat of the following kind would still be most timely. Whoever acts as a guardian to a girl or a boy, and any guardian of the law who has been put in charge of a guardian, is to be just as affectionate to an orphan as to his own offspring, ^{928b} and shall look after the property of someone under his care just as zealously as he looks after his own property, or even better. Anyone acting as a guardian shall adhere to this single law about orphans. If anyone acts

otherwise in such matters, contrary to the law, then in ^{928c} the case of a guardian, the official is to fine him, and in the case of an official, the guardian is to take him before the court of selected judges and fine him twice the penalty adjudged by the court. If a guardian is deemed by the child's relatives, or any of the other citizens, to have neglected his duty or acted badly, he is to be brought to the same court. And on conviction, he is to pay four times the assessed damages, one half being payable to the child and the other half to whoever brought the case. Once an orphan has come of age, he may take legal action in relation to his guardianship within a five-year period from its termination, ^{928d} if he believes the guardian behaved badly. And if the guardian is found guilty, the court is to impose the appropriate penalty or fine. If, however, one of the officials is deemed to have harmed an orphan through neglect, the court is to decide the amount he is to pay to the child, but if he harmed him through an unjust act, then in addition to the fine, he is to be removed from office as a guardian of the law, and the civic authority is to appoint another in his place for the country and the city. Disputes can arise between fathers and their own sons, and between sons and their fathers, that are more serious than they should be. In such cases, the fathers are inclined to the view that the lawgiver should grant them the legal right, if they wish, to proclaim publicly ^{928e} through the herald that their son is no longer legally their son, while sons, in turn, expect to be allowed to take legal action claiming insanity on the part of their fathers because they are laid low by sickness or old age. Such situations tend to arise from the thoroughly bad characters of the people involved, since if the badness was on one side only, the son being bad but not the father, or vice versa, the difficulties would not give rise to such a degree of hostility. Now, under another civic arrangement, a disinherited child would not necessarily lose the right of citizenship, but in our society, for which these laws are proposed, ^{929a} someone

who has been disowned by his father needs to resettle in another country, for the addition of one more household to our 5,040 holdings is not permitted. Therefore, whoever is to suffer this fate legally must be disowned, not alone by his father, but by the entire family. Such matters should be dealt with based upon a law, somewhat, as follows. If anyone, with justification or without, beset by accursed anger, wishes to expel from his own family someone whom he has begotten and reared, he should not be allowed to do so ^{929b} there and then without due process. He shall first gather his own kindred together, as far as cousins and his son's kindred on his mother's side in like manner, and lay his accusation before these people, explaining that his son deserves formal expulsion from the family by everyone. The son is to be given equal speaking time to argue that he does not deserve to suffer such a fate at all. If the father prevails and secures the votes of more than half of all ^{929c} the family members, excluding the votes of the father himself, the mother, the defendant, and any male or female who has not yet come of age, then in this way and upon these terms the father is permitted to disown his son, but not otherwise. If some citizen wants to adopt the disowned son as his own, no law should stand in the way, for the characters of the young naturally undergo numerous changes during their lives. But if within ten years no one offers ^{929d} to adopt the dispossessed son, those responsible for excess offspring who are about to be resettled elsewhere shall be responsible for such cases too, so that they may be duly included in the same resettlement. It may happen that sickness, old age, difficult behaviour, or indeed a combination of them all, makes someone exceptionally deranged and this goes unnoticed by everyone except those who live with him, and he squanders his own wealth as he has the authority to do so. His son, too, may be at a loss and be reluctant to take legal proceed- ^{929e} ings on grounds of insanity. In this case, let there be a law that decrees that the son should

first go to the most senior guardians of the law and describe the father's affliction. Having ^{930a} looked into the matter sufficiently, they are to advise him either to take legal action or not. If they advise him to proceed, they shall act both as witnesses and advocates for the prosecution, and if the father loses the case he is no longer to have the slightest authority to administer his own property, and he shall live out the rest of his life just like a child. If a husband and wife are no longer getting along with one another at all because their behaviour is so bad, ten of the guardians of the law, in middle age, should take constant ^{930b} charge of such people, along with ten of the women responsible for marriages. If they are able to bring about a reconciliation, such arrangements shall be binding, but if feelings are running too high, they shall do their best to find suitable alternative partners for each of them. Such people are unlikely to have gentle dispositions, and so they should try to match them with partners of a more sedate and gentle character. Disputants who are childless or who have very few children are to make the fresh match with a view to producing children, while those who have sufficient children should separate and form fresh unions for the sake of companionship and mutual care in their old age.

^{930c}

Athenian: If a wife dies leaving behind both male and female children, there shall be a law, advisory rather than prescriptive, that the father is to bring up the existing children without introducing a stepmother. If there are no children, the widower must remarry until such time as he has begotten sufficient children for his household and the city. If the husband dies leaving sufficient children behind, the mother of the children is to remain there and bring them up. But if she seems too youthful to live healthily without a husband, the relatives ^{930d} shall confer with the women responsible for marriage and do whatever seems best to themselves and the women. If there are not enough children, then children should be considered, and,

by law, one boy and one girl shall constitute a specified minimum. When the question of parentage is undisputed but a decision is required as to which parent a child should cleave to, the law is to be as follows; if a female slave lies with another slave or with a free man or a freedman, the offspring shall belong in every case to her master. If a free woman lies with a slave, the offspring is to belong to the slave's master; if a man has a child by his own ^{930e} slave or a woman by hers, and the facts are beyond dispute, then the women are to send the woman's child away to another country, along with its father, while the guardians of the law are to send the man's child away, along with the woman who bore it. No god or man with any sense would ever advise anyone to neglect parents, and we need to recognise that the following preamble concerning the worship of the gods would fit well with the subject of parental respect and disrespect. The ancient laws concerning the gods are, in every case, twofold. Some of the gods whom we honour are in plain sight, whereas we set up statues of others as images which we worship even though they are life- ^{931a} less, believing that those living gods, because of these images, are well disposed to us and grateful. So if anyone has a father or mother, or fathers and mothers, of such people, laid up like treasures in his home, infirm with old age, he should never presume that any statue could be more potent when he has a living image like this at home by his hearth, provided its possessor worships it in the right way.

^{931a}

Clinias: What do you mean by the right way?

Athenian: I shall tell you, for this sort of thing, my friends, deserves to be heard.

Clinias: Speak on.

^{931b}

Athenian: Oedipus, we say, having been dishonoured, called down curses upon his own children which by all accounts were heard by the gods, and fulfilled. Amyntor, in a fit of anger, cursed his own son Phoenix, Theseus cursed Hippolytus, and countless other fathers cursed just as many sons. These curses of parents upon their children are obviously heard by the gods, for it is only right that a parent's curse upon their offspring be unlike any other curse ^{931c} upon anyone else. Let's not suppose then that it is natural for a god to give a special hearing to the imprecations of a father or mother when they have been dishonoured by their children, yet when they are actually honoured and are very pleased about this and pray earnestly to the gods that good will befall their children, let's not believe that they do not pay just as much heed to prayers like these, and respond accordingly. No, if that were the case they would never be just in dispensing their blessings, and for gods that would really be most inappropriate.

^{931d}

Clinias: Indeed.

Athenian: And so, we should be of the view, as we said a little earlier, that we can possess no statue that is more honourable in the eyes of the gods than a father or grandfather laid low ^{931e} by old age, or a mother with the same capacity. When these people are exalted with honours, God rejoices, otherwise he would not hear their prayers. Indeed, for us, an ancestor is a wondrous image, more so than anything lifeless. For those that are alive always join in our prayers when we serve them, and pray against us when we do not, whereas the lifeless images do neither. And so, provided we treat fathers, grandfathers and anyone else of that sort in the right way, we would have images that are unsurpassed in securing a portion of divine favour.

^{931e}

Clinias: You expressed that very well.

Athenian: Anyone with any intelligence, then, fears and honours the prayers of parents, knowing ^{932a} that in many cases these have so often proved effective. And since this is the natural order of things, to good people aged ancestors are a boon to the very end of their lives and are deeply mourned by the young when they depart, while they are truly a source of fear to bad people. So, let everyone, in obedience to these precepts, honour their own parents with all the honours ordained by law, but in case someone is, by all accounts, deaf to such prelim- ^{932b} inaries, it is only right the following law should apply. If anyone in this city does not care for his parents as much as he should, and does not look after all their interests and comply with their wishes more so than his own sons, his own offspring and even himself, whoever suffers such neglect is to report this in person to the three most senior guardians of the law, and similarly to the three eldest women responsible for marriages. They shall take charge and punish the offenders with beating and imprisonment if they are young, up to the age of ^{932c} thirty for men and up to forty for women, who are to receive the same punishment. If they persist in this parental abuse or mistreatment when they are older than this, they should be brought before a court of 101 citizens, the most senior of all, and, if convicted, the court shall assess what the fine or punishment should be, without restriction, up to the limit of ^{932d} what a person is able to suffer or pay. If a victim is unable to speak on his own behalf, any free-born citizen who discovers the neglect is to report the matter to the officials or else be regarded as an evildoer and be liable to an action for damages by anyone who wishes. If a slave informs them, let him be set free. If the slave belongs to the victim or the perpetrator, he is to be freed by the court. If he belongs to some other citizen, the public treasury shall pay compensation for the slave to the owner, and the officials are to take care that no one wrongs the slave in revenge for acting as an informer.

932e

Athenian: Cases where one person harms another with poison with fatal consequences have already been dealt with, but other cases of injury where someone does harm using potions, foodstuffs or ointments, intentionally with premeditation, have not been dealt with so far. The fact that poisonings are of two kinds because of the nature of human beings is some- 933a thing we must pause to consider. One kind has just been described explicitly where bodies naturally injure other bodies. The other uses magic, enchantments and spells, not only to convince those who are intent upon doing harm that these measures are effective, but to convince their victims, above all, that they really are being harmed by these people who 933b are able to bewitch others. Now, in relation to all such matters, in general it is not easy to understand what precisely the natural state of affairs actually is, nor, having understood this, is it easy to convince others. But when people are suspicious of one another in their souls, there is no value in trying to convince them about this sort of thing and encourage them to think nothing of it if they behold some imitation moulded in wax in a doorway, or where three roads meet, or on a parent's grave, because they have no clear appreciation of 933c these matters. So, having made a twofold division in our law about poisoning depending upon how the person attempts to do it, we shall first request, exhort and counsel that such a deed never be attempted. Nor should anyone scare the general population like frightened children, nor indeed compel the lawgiver and judge to cure our people of such fears, because to begin with, the person trying to administer poison does not know what he is doing in the case of the body, unless he happens to be a knowledgeable physician, nor indeed in the case 933d of magic, unless he happens to be a prophet or diviner. So, let the law about poisoning be stated as follows: whoever poisons someone so as to do harm, not fatally, either to that person himself or to his people, or harms his

cattle or his hives, with or without fatal consequences, shall, if found guilty of poisoning, be put to death if he happens to be a physician, or if he be an ordinary citizen, the court shall impose the appropriate fine or penalty. If it is suspected that someone is apparently causing injury using spells, enchantments or charms, ^{933e} or any other poisonings of this sort, he is to be executed if he happens to be a prophet or diviner, but if he is convicted of poisoning with no knowledge of magic, then, as in the previous case, the court shall impose in this case too whatever fine or penalty it thinks he should suffer. In cases where one person injures another through theft or violence, the greater the injury, the greater the compensation payable to the injured party, and the smaller the injury, the lesser the compensation, but, above all, the compensation payable in every case is to be ^{934a} sufficient to make good the harm done. In addition, each offender shall pay the penalty associated with that particular crime to teach him self-control. When someone acts badly because of the folly of another person, being unduly influenced because of his youth or for some other reason, then the penalty should be lighter. However, when that bad deed is due to the person's own folly because of a lack of control over pleasure and pain, or due to incurable desires, envy or anger, then the penalty should be heavier. The penalty is not ^{934b} imposed because of the wrongdoing, for what has been done will never be undone, but with an eye to the future so that the wrongdoer himself, and those who see him being punished, will utterly detest the injustice, or at least recover to a large extent from such a dreadful affliction. For all these reasons, and with a view to everything of this sort, the laws, like a good archer, should aim to estimate the extent of the punishment in each case, and, above all, the amount of the compensation. The judge must lend assistance to the lawgiver when- ^{934c} ever, in executing the same task, the law entrusts him with assessing the punishment the defendant is to suffer or the compensation

he is to pay. The lawgiver, on the other hand, is to outline some actions that illustrate conformity to the written law. That, indeed, is what we must do now, Megillus and Clinias, as best and beautifully as we can. We should state what the penalty should be for any acts of theft or violence, insofar as the gods or their children allow us to enact such laws.

934d

Athenian: Someone who is insane is not to be at large in the city, and the relatives of such people are to keep them indoors by any means at their disposal, or else be subject to a fine, which, for the highest property class, shall be one hundred drachmas whether it is a slave or a free citizen that is being supervised. A member of the second class shall pay four fifths ^{934e} of a mina, the third class shall pay three fifths and the fourth class two fifths. Now, many people are insane and in many different ways. In the cases we are referring to now, the madness is due to diseases, but there are other cases where there is a bad innate tendency to anger which is actually fostered. Such people, in minor disputes, raise their voices to speak abusively and slanderously to one another, behaviour that is completely and utterly inappropriate in a well-regulated city. So, let there be a single law applicable to all cases of abusive speech, as follows: no one is to verbally abuse anyone else. Any party to a verbal dispute is to instruct and learn from his adversary and the company, refraining entirely from all verbal abuse. Indeed, when people call down curses upon one another and employ dis- ^{935a} graceful language in a shrewish tone, firstly, although the words are as light as air, from these spring deeds that are heavy with hatred and hostility. For the speaker is embracing anger, an unkind trait, feeding this urge to the full with a noxious banquet, and his soul, once made gentle through education, is made wild again, and he becomes a beast who lives in discontent, reaping the bitter harvest of his anger. What's more, all those involved in ^{935b} such encounters are

inclined all too often to resort, somehow or other, to mocking their opponent. And no one has ever adopted this habit without completely failing to retain their own dignity or, in large part, losing their mental power. For these reasons, no one in a sacred place is to express themselves in this way at all, nor at a public sacrifice, at the games, in the marketplace, in court, or at any public gathering. And every transgression is to be punished^{935c} by the official in charge on pain of being debarred from all public distinctions, as someone who neither cares about the laws nor heeds the injunctions of the lawgiver. In other situations, if someone either initiating the criticism or retaliating does not refrain from such language, anyone older who comes across him is to defend the law by driving out with blows those who are so fond of that evil companion, anger, or else be liable himself to the appointed penalty. So, we are now saying that when someone is involved in criticism, he^{935d} cannot help attempting to resort to mockery, and this, when it is born of anger, is what we are criticising. But what about the comic writers who are keen on mocking people? Are we to accept this provided they resort to this sort of mockery of our citizens without any anger? Or are we to make a distinction between mockery in jest and mockery that is serious, and allow anyone to mock anyone else without anger, but not allow them, as we have said, to do so^{935e} in earnest and in anger? This stipulation must not be retracted, but we must pass laws stating who may do this and who may not. No composer of a comedy or any iambic or lyric song should be allowed to mock any of our citizens, either in word or through imitation, whether or not this is done in anger. If any of them disobeys this law, the officials in charge of the^{936a} competition are to expel him from the area entirely, on that very day, or be fined three minae, dedicated to the god in whose honour the competition is being held. Those with permission, as we said earlier, to compose works about one another are allowed to engage in mockery in

jest, but not in earnest or in a spirit of anger. Determination in this matter is to be left to the person responsible for the overall education of the young, and the composer shall be allowed to publicly present whatever that person approves, but whatever he rejects must ^{936b} not be shown to anyone else, nor should he ever be found teaching it to any other person, slave or free born, on pain of being regarded as a rogue who does not heed the laws. It is not the person who is hungry or who suffers a similar misfortune who deserves to be pitied, but the person who is sound-minded or possessed of some excellence, even in part, who comes by misfortune in addition. So it would be surprising if someone like this, slave or free, were to be totally neglected and reduced to utter beggary in a society or city that was even moderately well managed. Therefore, there will be no threat to such people ^{936c} if the lawgiver enacts a law somewhat as follows. There is to be no begging in our city, and if someone attempts to engage in such behaviour, scraping a life together through incessant entreaties, the market police are to expel him from the marketplace, and the board of city police are to expel him from the city, and the rural police from the rest of the country, driving him beyond the border so that our land may be entirely purged of such creatures. If a slave, male or female, damages anything at all that belongs to other people, and the injured party himself is not partly responsible through ineptitude or some other irre- ^{936d} sponsible actions, the owner of the slave that did the damage shall either make good the damage in full, or hand that slave over to the victim. But if the slave's owner issues a counter claim that the charge involves collusion between the injured party and the culprit slave in order to deprive him of that slave, he may take an action for conspiracy against the person who claims to have suffered the damage, and if he is successful he is to receive twice the value that the court sets upon the slave, but if he loses he is to pay for the damage and hand over the slave. And if a draught animal, a

horse or a dog, or some other beast, damages ^{936e} anything belonging to a neighbour, compensation is to be paid on the same basis. If someone won't of his own volition act as a witness, the person who needs his evidence shall summon him as a witness, and once summoned he shall appear in court, and if he has information and is willing to give evidence, he should do so. But if he claims to have no information, let him swear an oath to Zeus, Apollo and Themis, denying any knowledge, and be excused from the case. But a person called as a witness who does not show up in court in response is liable by law to an action for damages. If someone calls one of the judges at this trial to ^{937a} act as a witness, then, having given evidence, the judge must not vote in that case. A free woman is allowed to act as a witness or to support someone's case provided she is over forty, and she may initiate a legal action herself if she has no husband, but if she has a husband who is alive, she may only act as a witness. A slave, male or female, or a child, is permitted to act as a witness or a support only in a murder trial, provided that individual furnishes a trustworthy guarantor to ensure that the witness will remain and await trial in ^{937b} case the evidence is challenged as false. Either side in a case may challenge all or part of the evidence before the verdict has been decided if he maintains that he is a victim of false witness. The officials shall keep the challenges by both parties safely sealed up, and shall produce them at the trial for false witness. If a person is twice convicted of false witness, no law shall compel him to act as a witness thereafter. If it happens three times, he shall no ^{937c} longer be permitted to act as a witness, and if he dares to give evidence having been convicted three times, anyone who wishes may report him to the authorities, who shall bring him to court, and, if convicted, he shall be sentenced to death. In cases where evidence is condemned by a court and it is adjudged that someone gave false evidence and ensured that the victorious party won the case, then if more than half

his evidence is condemned, the case that was lost on that basis should be subject to review, and there should be argument and an adjudication as to whether or not the original case was decided by the false evi- ^{937d} dence, and this adjudication, whatever the outcome, shall determine how the previous cases conclude. Although there are many fine things in human life, most of them are beset by a sort of plague that pollutes and defiles them. And, indeed, justice among us humans is undeniably something fine which has civilised the life of man, and since this is fine, how could judicial advocacy not be fine too? But a pernicious skill hiding behind a noble name brings these fine things into disrepute. It begins by claiming that there is a certain contrivance for ^{937e} dealing with judicial proceedings, which itself constitutes a means of conducting a case and advocating on behalf of someone else, being capable of ensuring victory regardless of whether the behaviour of the defendant in the case had been just or not. It also claims that this skill and the arguments it produces may be had as a gift to anyone who hands over ^{938a} money. Now, regardless of whether this skill is indeed a skill or just a knack based upon practice devoid of skill, it should never, if possible, take root in our city. The lawgiver asks for obedience, that they don't speak contrary to justice, or that they depart to another country, and if they comply, he has no more to say. If they do not comply, then the voice of the ^{938b} law is as follows. Anyone suspected of attempting to turn the force of justice in the souls of the jurors to the very opposite course, or of taking multiple legal actions opportunistically, or advocating for others in such actions, is liable to prosecution by anyone who wishes, for perversion of justice or supporting others in such perversion. The case should be tried by the court of selected judges, and, on conviction, the court is to determine whether the defen- ^{938c} dant was acting out of greed or out of ambition. If ambition was the motive, the court is to decide for how long such a person is to be debarred from taking a legal

action against anyone else, or from advocacy in a legal action. If the motive was greed, a foreigner is to be banished from the country, never to return, on pain of death, while a native, because he was motivated by such out and out greed, is to be put to death. Someone who is convicted of doing this sort of thing out of ambition, for a second time, is to be put to death.

BOOK XII

941a

Athenian: If someone acting as an ambassador or envoy executes his embassy unfaithfully by lying about his city to another city, or by failing to convey the actual representations he was sent to convey, or he obviously misreports the message from hostile or friendly cities in his role as ambassador or envoy, let the offender be charged with unlawful impiety against the messages and edicts of Zeus and Hermes. If he is convicted, there should be an assessment ^{941b} of the fine he should pay or the punishment he should suffer. Theft of property is unworthy of a free person, while open robbery is a disgrace. No son of Zeus, taking delight in fraud or violence, has ever engaged in either of these. So, let no one who commits such offences be misled or deceived, by the poets or any other perverse storytellers, and come to believe that thieving and violence is the very behaviour of the gods themselves, rather than a shameful act. Indeed, this is neither true nor plausible, and whoever does this sort of thing in contra- ^{941c} vention of the law is no god, nor indeed a child of a god. And it belongs to the lawgiver to be more aware of this than all the poets put together. Now, whoever heeds our precept is fortunate and endures in good fortune, while whoever heeds it not shall come thereafter into conflict with the following law. The penalty is to be the same whether theft of public property be on a large scale or a small scale. For when someone steals something minor, he ^{941d} does so with the same desire but with less capacity, while the

person who takes up something major, something he himself has not put down, is wholly unjust. So the law sees fit to impose a lesser penalty on one than on the other, not because of the scale of the theft, but on the grounds that one is perhaps curable while the other is beyond cure. Accordingly, if someone secures a conviction in court against a slave or foreigner for theft of public property, the ^{942a} court is to decide what fine should be paid or what punishment should be suffered since the person is in all probability curable, while a citizen, brought up as our citizens will be brought up, once convicted of plundering or doing violence to his fatherland, whether he is caught in the act or not, is to be put to death as someone who is more or less beyond cure. When it comes to military organisation, much deliberation and many laws are in order, but what's most important is that everyone, male or female, should always be under authority. Nor should anyone develop in soul the habit of acting autonomously, just by themselves, either in serious matters or in play. Rather, both in time of war and in time of ^{942b} peace, they should live looking always to and following an authority, and be guided thereby even in the slightest details such as halting when ordered to do so, advancing, exercising, washing, eating, awakening at night for guard duty or to act as a messenger, and, in the face of danger, neither pursuing nor retreating without the commander's signal. In a word, he is ^{942c} to teach his soul, by habituation, to have no awareness or appreciation whatsoever of performing any action separately from other people, so that life is lived as much as possible together, collectively, in a community of all with all. For there is not, nor shall there ever ^{942d} be, a means of ensuring our safety and victory in war that is as powerful, as good, or as effective as this. So, in peacetime, the practice of ruling others and being under someone else's authority should be encouraged from earliest childhood, while absence of authority should be eradicated entirely from human life, and indeed from the life of

all animals under human control. Furthermore, all choral dances should be performed with an eye to military excellence, and all training in dexterity and fortitude should be for the same purpose, as well as the patient toleration of the pangs of hunger and thirst, of heat and cold, and of hard beds. But what is most important is not to destroy the capacity of the head and feet to produce and grow their own felt and footwear by swathing them in unnatural coverings. For ^{942e} these extremities, when kept safe, preserve the power of the entire body at its utmost, while their neglect has the opposite effect. One is the body's greatest servant, while the other is its supreme ruler, naturally holding all of its dominant sense organs.

^{943a}

Athenian: Such is the praise of the military life to which the young should have decided to listen. The laws, on the other hand, are as follows: whoever is enlisted or assigned any role is to perform military service. If anyone, out of cowardice, is absent without the permission of the generals, he is to be tried for desertion before the army officers when they return from the campaign, and each division that served on the campaign is to judge the cases separately. Hoplites, cavalry, and the various other divisions of the military are all to follow the same procedure – hoplites being brought before hoplites, cavalrymen before cavalrymen, ^{943b} and so on for all the others, each appearing before their own colleagues. Whoever is convicted is to be debarred from ever competing for any distinctions, from prosecuting another for desertion, or from being an accuser in such cases. Furthermore, the court is to determine what additional penalty he is to suffer or what fine he is to pay. After this, once the trials for desertion have been decided, the officers of each division are to meet again, and whoever so wishes may be judged by his own peers in relation to his military distinctions, furnishing ^{943c} no evidence or supporting witness statements from any previous wars, apart from the campaign

they have just concluded. The victory prize in such cases shall be an olive wreath, which he may hang with an inscription in any temple of the gods of war he chooses, to bear witness for the rest of his life that he has been awarded the highest of military distinctions, or the second or third highest as the case may be. If someone involved in a military campaign goes home before the appointed time without permission of his officers, he is to stand ^{943d} trial for leaving the field, before the same people who try the cases of desertion, and, on conviction, the same penalties as prescribed previously are to be imposed. Anyone bringing a legal action against another should of course be as fearful as he can of the imposition of an undeserved penalty, whether intended or unintended. For justice is indeed, and has been truly called, the virgin daughter of reverence. And by their very nature, reverence and justice abhor falsehood. So, we should in general be careful of transgressions against justice, especially in the case of loss of weapons in battle, lest we completely misjudge cases where loss ^{943e} of weapons was unavoidable, censure such losses as shameful, and visit undeserved retribution upon an innocent man.

^{944a}

Athenian: Now, it is not at all easy to distinguish between these various cases. Nevertheless, the law must somehow attempt to differentiate one from the other. We may use a story to illustrate the point. Suppose Patroclus, having been brought to his tent without his armour, had revived there, as has happened to countless others, it would have been possible for the base folk of the time to censure the son of Menoetios for losing the weapons, which according to the poet had been given to Peleus by the gods as a dowry with his wife, Thetis.¹⁰⁷ There ^{944b} are people, too, who lose their weaponry when they are thrown from a height, or at sea, or from the sudden impact received from a great gush of water in a storm. Or one could come ^{944c} up with an endless variety of similar excuses to gloss over a

suspicious misfortune. It is necessary then to distinguish, as best we can, the more significant and problematic misfortune from its opposite. Now, the application of these epithets as a criticism does involve a distinction of sorts. For it would not be justifiable, in all cases, to refer to such a person as a 'shield-thrower' rather than as someone who had merely lost his weapons. For the person who loses his weapons under duress would not be a shield-thrower in the same way as someone who discards them willingly. The two cases are completely and entirely different. So let the law state the following: if someone, in possession of weapons, is overtaken by the enemy combatants and does not turn around and defend himself, but deliberately drops his weapons or throws them away – winning a life of shame through his cowardice, rather ^{944d} than a noble and blessed death through sheer courage – there shall be punishment for such loss of weapons that are thrown away. But in the other case we mentioned, the judge is to ensure that an investigation is carried out. Indeed, the coward should always be punished in order to make him a better man, but there is no point in punishing the unfortunate. But what penalty would be appropriate for someone who throws away such powerful defensive weaponry in an act of cowardice? Now, it is said that a god once transformed Caeneus of Thessaly,¹⁰⁸ a woman, into a man, and although no human can do the opposite and turn a man into a woman, if this penalty had been inflicted upon the fellow who threw away his shield, and he had been turned into a woman, that would in a way have been the most fitting ^{944e} penalty of all. But as matters stand, to get as close to this arrangement as possible because of the man's attachment to life, let the following law apply to such a person so that he may live on without peril for as long as possible, and put up with being reviled as a coward. A man who is convicted of shamefully throwing away his weapons of war shall not, thereafter, be employed as a soldier by any general or any other

army officer, nor may he be assigned ^{945a} any other military position whatsoever. Otherwise, whoever gives the coward a posting is to be fined one thousand drachmas by the auditor if he belongs to the highest property class, five hundred if he belongs to the second, three hundred if he belongs to the third and one hundred if he belongs to the fourth. The convicted soldier, besides being excluded by nature from perilous manly exploits, shall also pay a fine of one thousand drachmas if he belongs to the highest property class, five hundred if he belongs to the second, three hundred if he belongs to the third, and one hundred as before if he belongs to the fourth.

^{945b}

Athenian: What do we have to say that is appropriate to the auditors, some of whom are appointed by lot for one year, while others are appointed from a panel for a number of years? Who will be competent to audit such people if one of them somehow acts awry, weighed down by the burden of his office and his own inability to give the role what it deserves? Now, although it is not at all easy to find an overseer for overseers, someone who ^{945c} is pre-eminent in excellence, we should nevertheless make the effort to find some auditors who are divine. This is how matters stand. There are many critical factors involved in the dissolution of a political system, just as there are in the case of a ship or a living organism, with their stays and braces and tendons and sinews, a single nature dispersed multifariously and referred to by a variety of names. One significant factor critical in the preservation of a political system, or its dissolution and ruination, are auditors. For if those who audit the ^{945d} officials are better than them, and this role is exercised irreproachably with blameless justice, then the entire country and city thrives and is happy. But if the auditing of the officials ^{945e} is conducted improperly, then justice, which holds all civic functions together, is subverted, every public office is torn apart from every other, and they are no longer inclined in the

same direction, thus turning the city into many cities rather than one, so full of faction that it is soon destroyed. That's why auditors need to be totally exemplary in all forms of excellence.

946a

Athenian: Let's arrange, then, to produce these people in some such manner as this. Each year after the summer solstice, the entire city should assemble in the common precinct of Helios and Apollo to present to the god, from among themselves, three men over fifty years of age, apart from themselves, whom each of them regards as the best in every respect. They shall choose half of those who have been nominated, those who obtain the most votes if their number is even. If their number is odd, the person with the least votes shall be eliminated, retaining half the nominees as determined by the number of votes cast. If some 946b receive an equal number of votes, thus making the half too large, the excess is to be eliminated by removing the youngest, while the rest are to be carried forward to another vote. And the process is to be repeated until three people with an unequal number of votes remain. If all three, or two of them, get the same vote, they shall entrust the outcome to benign fate and to fortune by deciding first, second and third place by lot, and crown them with olive wreaths. Once the appointments have been made, they are to proclaim to everyone that the 946c city of the Magnesians, safe once more under God, is presenting its three foremost personages to Helios, and according to the ancient law it dedicates the pick of its manhood as a joint offering to Apollo and Helios for as long as they hold judicial office. Twelve such auditors shall be appointed in the first year, each to hold office until they turn seventy-five, and thereafter three new members are to be added each year. The auditors, having divided the officials into twelve groups, are to scrutinise them by applying every test worthy of free people. For as long as they are serving as auditors, they should reside in the very precinct 946d of Apollo and Helios, in which they were elected.

Once they have passed judgement upon the city officials, whilst acting sometimes on their own, sometimes in consultation with one another, they are to display a written record in the marketplace stating what punishment or fine each official is to incur according to the decision of the auditors. Any official who believes he has been judged unjustly may bring the auditors before the court of selected judges, and, if he is acquitted of the auditors' charges, he may, if he wishes, take an action ^{946e} against the auditors themselves. But if he is convicted, and he has already been sentenced to death by the auditors, then he need simply be executed, while in the case of other penalties that are capable of being doubled, let him pay double the penalty.

^{947a}

Athenian: It is necessary to hear about audits of these auditors themselves, and how they are to be conducted. These people, who have been deemed worthy of the highest distinctions by the entire city, are to have seats of honour for life at all the festivals. From this group of people, official representatives are to be sent out to any sacrifices common to all Greeks, to any spectacles, or to any other sacred gatherings. They alone, of all the city's inhabitants, are to be adorned with a laurel wreath. All are to be priests of Apollo and Helios, and the chief priest for the year is to be the one who comes first in that year's election, and the year ^{947b} shall be recorded under his name as a means of reckoning the date for as long as the city survives. When they die, their lying in state, funeral procession and burial are to be different from those of the other citizens. The raiment shall be all white, and there shall be no dirges or laments. A chorus of fifteen maidens and another of fifteen youths, each standing about the bier, shall in turn chant a sort of hymn of praise to the priests celebrating them in song throughout the entire day. At dawn the next day, the bier itself is to be escorted to the tomb ^{947c} by one hundred youths belonging to the gymnasia, as chosen by the relatives of the deceased, led by the unwed soldiers with

their military accompaniments – cavalrymen with ^{947d} their horses, hoplites with their armour, and so on for all the others. Around the bier, the boys, being in front, shall sing the national chant, with the maidens following behind, while the women past childbearing come next. After this shall come the priests and priestesses, even though they are excluded from other burials, as if they were going to an undefiled tomb, provided the voice of the Pythian prophetess lends it support. Their tomb is to be constructed beneath the earth, oblong, made of porous stone, as ageless as can be, fitted with stone benches placed side by side. Once the blessed dead have been laid there, earth ^{947e} shall be piled up in a circle, and they shall plant a grove of trees round about, except at one end so that the tomb may be extended in that direction, with no mound covering those who are placed there. Every year they shall hold a contest in music, gymnastics and horse-racing in their honour.

^{947e}

Athenian: These are the honours due to those who have passed scrutiny at their audit. But if any of them, relying upon the fact of their election, proves himself all too human by turning bad after they have been appointed, the law shall ordain that anyone who wishes may prosecute them, and the trial shall be conducted in a court constituted as follows. Its first mem- ^{948a}bers shall be the guardians of the law, then the auditors themselves who are still alive, and finally the court of selected judges. Whoever brings a charge against someone else is to state that such and such a person is unworthy of those distinctions, and of the office he holds. And if he is found guilty as charged, he is to be deprived of his office, of that burial, and of the other honours bestowed upon him. But if the prosecutor fails to obtain one fifth of the votes, he is to be fined twelve minae if he belongs to the highest property class, eight ^{948b} if he belongs to the second highest, six minae for the third and three for the fourth.

948b

Athenian: Rhadamanthus is worthy of our admiration for the way he is said to have judged legal cases, because he discerned that human beings at the time were quite certain of the existence of the gods, as well they might be, since most people in those days were the offspring of gods, himself included, as the story goes. He seems then to have concluded that he should place his trust, not in any human judges, but in the gods, and so he arrived at simple, quick judgements. For he administered an oath to the contending parties regarding each issue under dispute, and thus secured a rapid, secure resolution. But nowadays, we ^{948c} say, a portion of the human race does not believe in the gods at all, while others are of the view that they don't concern themselves with us humans, while the opinion of the worst people, who are the most numerous, is that in return for some paltry sacrifices and flatteries, the gods help them to commit fraud on a vast scale and to evade all sorts of grievous penal- ^{948d} ties. Therefore, the skill of Rhadamanthus would no longer be appropriate in legal proceedings for people of this era. Since people's beliefs about the gods have changed, the laws must change too. Indeed, a lawgiver possessed of reason should abolish the oaths of both adversaries in legal proceedings, and whoever is taking an action against another should simply write out the charges without swearing an oath, and the defendant, similarly, should write out his denial and hand it over to the officials without swearing an oath. Indeed, with so much legal activity taking place in a city, it is surely terrible to know full well that ^{948e} although close to half of those involved are perjurers, they have no compunction about associating with one another at common meals, or at other public gatherings or private meetings. Let the law then decree that a judge who is about to give judgement is to swear an oath. Someone appointing a public official is always to do so under oath or using a voting pebble ^{949a} taken from a sacred place, as should a

judge of choruses or musical performances and any umpires or adjudicators of gymnastic or equestrian competitions, or of any matters where the outcome confers no advantage upon someone who breaks his oath, as far as we can humanly see. But in situations where there is an obvious and significant advantage in deny- 949b ing the truth, and doing so under oath, then the various accusers and counter-accusers should be judged through judicial proceedings without any oaths being sworn. And, in general, during the trial the presiding judges should not allow anyone to speak under oath in order to make his case more persuasive, or to lend solemnity to his curses upon himself and his clan, and they should prohibit any recourse to grovelling appeals or emotional outpourings. They are to ensure that everyone always explains the justice of their case in respectful language, and hears the other side. Otherwise, those in charge shall bring them back to the 949c point at issue, the point from which they had digressed. In cases of one foreigner against another, exchanges of oaths are to be accepted if desired, just as they are nowadays, and they may be granted legal authority, since these people, for the most part, shall not grow old and build homesteads in our city, thus producing others like themselves with legal status in our country, and similar habits. Their private legal actions against one another are also to be decided in the same manner.

949c

Athenian: There may be situations where a free citizen is disobedient to the city, cases that do not merit whipping or imprisonment or execution, relating perhaps to attendance at choruses or processions or involvement in other public ceremonies, or services such as sacrifices in time of peace or special impositions in time of war. In all such cases, the first requirement 949d is to make good the harm done, and for the offenders to give security to those whom the city and the law authorise to demand it, and if they disregard their pledges,

there is to be a sale of the securities and the funds are to go to the city. If further penalties are required, the relevant officials, having imposed the appropriate penalties on the offenders, are to bring them before the court until they are prepared to do as they are bidden.

949e

Athenian: A city whose sole source of wealth is the produce of the earth, and which does not engage in commercial activity, needs to decide what to do about foreign travel by its own citizens, and the admission of foreigners from elsewhere. Now, the lawgiver should begin by giving advice on these matters as persuasively as he can. This intermingling of cities with cities naturally combines a whole variety of customs, as strangers introduce novel behaviour to citizens, and citizens do the same to strangers. This does the greatest harm to cities that are well governed under proper laws, although in most cases, since the cities are ^{950a} not at all well governed, the intermingling makes no difference, whether it occurs by receiving strangers into their midst, or when they themselves travel for fun to other cities out of a desire for foreign travel of some sort, either when young or in their later years. Then again, it is not feasible to impose a total ban on the admission of strangers and on foreign travel by our own people. And what's more, this might appear like aggressive, rough treatment to the world at large, and we might get a reputation for using the harsh language of the so-^{950b} called 'alien expulsions', and for behaving in an inflexible and cruel manner. Indeed, we should never make light of our good or bad reputation in the eyes of others, for although most people fall far short of true excellence, that does not prevent them from judging the extent to which others are good or evil. There is a divine intuition present even in the bad people, so that the vast majority, even of extreme evildoers, do a good job of distinguishing, ^{950c} in their views and in how they express them, between the better people and the worse. So, the

exhortation to set a high value upon a good reputation in the eyes of the world is sound advice for most cities. In fact, what's most important and most correct is truly being good, and seeking a good reputation in this way, not, if we mean to be complete, by omitting the actual goodness. And, indeed, it would be fitting for the city we are founding in Crete to ^{950d} attain a most glorious and exalted reputation for excellence in the eyes of the world. For there is every reasonable hope, provided our plan is followed, that it will be among the few well-governed cities and regions under the gaze of the sun and the other gods.

^{950e}

Athenian: Now, what should be done about travels abroad to other regions and places, and the admission of foreigners, is as follows. Firstly, no one under the age of forty is to be allowed to travel abroad under any circumstances whatsoever. No one may ever do so for personal reasons, but such travel is to be permitted on public business as an envoy or ambassador, or to attend certain ceremonies. We should send representatives to Apollo at Delphi, to Zeus at Olympia, Nemea and the Isthmus to partake in the sacrifices and competitions in honour of those gods, doing our best to send delegations that are as noble, as distinguished and as ^{951a} large as possible, thus promoting the good reputation of the city at those sacred, peaceful gatherings, conferring a renown comparable to their military prestige. On returning home, they shall teach the younger folk that the customs of other cities are in second place compared to their own civic arrangements. There are other envoys who may, with the permission of the guardians of the law, be sent abroad. They are as follows. If any citizens wish to study the manners of other peoples, and have sufficient leisure to do so, no law shall stand ^{951b} in their way. For a city with no experience of people, both good and bad, would never, in its isolation, be able to become sufficiently civilised or perfect, nor indeed would it ever be able

to safeguard its own laws without appreciating them intelligently rather than through mere habit. In fact, there are always, among the broad mass of humanity, some few divine personages whose company is of the utmost value, and they spring up just as much in badly governed cities as in those that are well governed. The inhabitant of a well-governed city, who is incorruptible, should constantly seek out the traces of such people, going by land and by sea, with the aim of developing a confidence in any practices of his own people that ^{951c} are in good order, and of introducing corrections where there are any defects. For without this scrutiny and enquiry, or if this is badly conducted, no city ever remains perfect.

^{951c}

Clinias: How may we achieve both objectives?

Athenian: As follows. Firstly, an envoy of this sort is to be over fifty years of age and to have secured a good reputation in general, and in military affairs too, if he is to be sent abroad ^{951d} to other cities as proof of what the guardians of the law can produce. Once he turns sixty he may no longer act as an envoy. Having served in this role for as much of the ten years as he wishes, and then returned home, he is to report to the council that has oversight of the laws. This is to be a body composed of younger and older members, which has to meet every day from daybreak until the sun has risen.¹⁰⁹ It shall consist firstly of priests who have ^{951e} achieved high distinction, secondly of the ten most senior guardians of the law, and finally of whoever is currently responsible for all education, and those who have retired from this role. Each of these shall attend not on his own, but accompanied by a young man of his own choosing, aged between thirty and forty. Their meeting and discussions shall always ^{952a} deal with the laws of their own city, and anything they may learn about such matters from some other places, and, indeed, any subjects that may seem beneficial to learn for their

enquiry, because such studies bring clarity to the consideration of the laws, while their neglect clouds the matter in darkness and obscurity. The young folk shall, with all eagerness, study any of the subjects that the elders approve, but if any of those who are encouraged to undertake this study prove unworthy, the entire council is to censure the person who invited ^{952b} them. The rest of the city is to take responsibility for those young people who have a good reputation by keeping a special eye on them, and taking care of them, honouring them when they act aright, and dishonouring them more than their fellows if their behaviour falls below the general standard.

^{952b}

Athenian: The person who has surveyed the customs of other peoples is to proceed to this coun- ^{952c} cil as soon as he gets back home, and if he has come across people who are able to state some principle concerning legislation, education or the rearing of children, or he has brought back some reflections of his own, he is to share these with the entire council. If he seems to have returned neither better off nor worse off, he should be praised nevertheless for his eager enthusiasm. If he has returned in a better position, he is to receive much more praise in his lifetime, and when he dies, the authority of the council shall honour him with fitting tributes. If it turns out on his return that he has been corrupted, he should never gain the company of anyone else, old or young, by pretending to be wise, and if he manages to reassure the officials, he may live a private life. Otherwise, if he is convicted in court of busying ^{952d} himself in the field of education or laws, he is to be put to death. If he deserves to be brought to court, but none of the officials brings him to trial, this shall count to their discredit in the decision about awards of distinction.

^{952d}

Athenian: So much for the sort of people who may travel abroad, and how they may do so. Our next concern is the visitor

from abroad and how he should be welcomed. There are four kinds of visitors for whom we should make provision. First is a relentless, perpetual arrival who usually makes his repeated visits in summer, after the manner of migratory birds. Most of these cross the sea as if they had wings, flying all summer long to various cities to conduct ^{952e} trade and make money. The officials who have been put in charge of these matters should receive this visitor at marketplaces, harbours and public buildings close to the city, but outside its walls, ensuring that no visitors of this sort introduce any innovations. They shall administer justice to them and interact with them as much as necessary, but as little as possible. The second visitor is a true observer, who sees various sights with his eyes and hears musical displays with his ears. All such arrivals must be accommodated at the temples and provided with generous hospitality by the priests and wardens who are to look after them ^{953a} carefully. They may remain for a reasonable period of time, seeing and hearing whatever they came for, and they should then depart with no harm done or suffered. Should anyone do an injustice to them, or they to another, the priests are to act as their judges provided the sum involved is less than fifty drachmas. If the claim exceeds that amount, the case is to be tried before the rural commissioners. The third visitor who should be received by the state is one who arrives on public business from another region. They are to be received only by ^{953b} generals, cavalry commanders and infantry commanders, and their care should be the sole responsibility, in consultation with the prytanes, of whichever commander the visitor is residing with as a guest. The fourth kind of visitor arrives rarely, if ever. But if someone from another region ever does arrive who is the counterpart of our own observers, he is firstly required to be over fifty years of age, and, what's more, he is to be here in the expectation either of seeing something fine, something superior in beauty to what is found in ^{953c} other cities,

or of showing something of the same sort to another city. Now, any such visitor may go uninvited to the doors of the wealthy and the wise, since he himself is a person of that sort. Indeed, he may go to the home of the person in charge of all education, confident in the propriety of being the guest of such a host, or to the home of someone who has received official recognition for his excellence. Having spent time with these people, teaching and being taught, let him depart as a friend taking his leave of friends, bestowing suitable ^{953d} gifts and marks of honour. By these laws, all visitors, both male and female, are to be received from other regions, and our own people are to be sent abroad, honouring Zeus, the god of strangers, not driving visitors away with our eating habits and rituals, as the people of the Nile do nowadays, or by issuing harsh edicts.

^{953e}

Athenian: If anyone gives a guarantee, let him do so explicitly, agreeing the entire transaction in a written contract in front of witnesses, at least three for a contract under one thousand ^{954a} drachmas, and at least five if it exceeds that sum. A broker in any sale is to act as a guarantor for a seller without legal title to the goods, or one who is generally untrustworthy, and he is to be just as liable to prosecution as the seller. Someone who wishes to search someone else's property for stolen goods is to strip to his shirt and wear no belt, and swear an oath to the legally prescribed gods that he really expects to find something. He may then conduct his search. The other party shall allow him to search his house, including whatever is sealed or unsealed. But if one party wishes to conduct a search while the other refuses to allow ^{954b} this, the one who has been refused access may take legal action, specifying the value of the item he is looking for, and the other party, if convicted, shall pay double its value in damages. If the master of the house happens to be away at the time, the members of the household shall hand over whatever is unsealed to be searched, and whatever has been

sealed is to receive a second seal from the searcher, who is to appoint someone of his own choosing to stand guard for five days. And if the master is away for a longer period of time, the city police are to be brought in, and the search conducted accordingly by breaking the seals and resealing them again as before, in the presence of the household members and the city police.

954c

Athenian: In cases of disputes over property, there is to be a time limit as follows, after which someone who has acquired the item shall no longer be open to challenge. In our city there is no such thing as a dispute over land or houses. In the case of any other possessions that someone has acquired, if he has been using the item openly in the city, the marketplace and the temples, with no one making a claim, and someone asserts that he has been looking for the item all this time, although its possessor was obviously not hiding it, and this goes on 954d for a year with one person in possession of the item and the other seeking it, then once the year has elapsed no one is to be allowed to lay claim to the item. If the item is used openly in a rural area but not in the city or the marketplace, and no one challenges its possession for five years, then once the five years have elapsed no one shall be allowed to lay claim to such an item. If someone uses the item at his home in the city, the prescribed time period 954e is to be three years. For undisclosed use in a rural area the period shall be ten years, but when the item was being used in a foreign country there is to be no time limit for a claim, regardless of when it is found. If anyone forcibly prevents a person or his witnesses from appearing in court, and the person hindered is a slave, either his own or someone else's, the case shall be declared null and void. But if the person hindered is a free citizen, then, in addition to the nullification of the case, the offender is to be imprisoned for one year, and 955a is to be liable to prosecution for kidnapping by

anyone who wishes. If anyone forcibly prevents a rival in a gymnastic or musical or other competition from making an appearance, whoever wishes may inform the competition presidents, who are to grant the person who wished to compete the freedom to enter the contest. But if they are unable to do so, and victory goes to the entrant who hindered his rival, they shall award the prize to the hindered ^{955b} party, and commemorate the victory in whatever temples he chooses, while the offender is to be barred from setting up an offering or inscription relating to such a competition, and he shall be liable to pay damages whether he was victorious or not.

^{955b}

Athenian: If anyone knowingly receives any stolen item, he is to be liable to the same penalty as the thief, and for receiving someone who has been exiled the penalty shall be death. Everyone is to regard the city's friend or enemy as his own. And anyone who makes peace ^{955c} or war privately with others, without common consent, is also to be liable to the death penalty. If part of the city makes peace or war with any for itself, the generals are to bring those responsible for this action to court, and on conviction the penalty shall be death.

^{955c}

Athenian: Those who serve the nation are to render such service without accepting gifts, and there is to be no excusing this, or praise for the argument that "good deeds deserve gifts ^{955d} while foul deeds do not". For it is not easy to know what to do and then stand by what you know, and it is safest to heed and obey the law that no service be done in return for gifts. Whoever disobeys, shall, on conviction in court, simply be put to death. In relation to financial contributions to the common fund, not only must the property of each citizen be valued for various reasons, but a tribal official shall also present a written record of the annual production to the rural commissioners so that the treasury may decide which of the two kinds of

contributions it wishes to employ, choosing year by year either to take part of the overall valuation or a portion of the annual income in that particular year, after the deduction of the costs of the common meals.

955e

Athenian: The reasonable man should present moderate offerings to the gods. Now, land and the household hearth are always sacred to all gods, so let no one consecrate to the gods for a second time that which is already sacred. Gold and silver, possessions that are used in other cities both in private and in the temples, are a source of jealousy, while ivory, coming from a body that came to be devoid of soul, is an unclean offering, and iron and bronze are instruments of war. Anyone may present at the public temples any wooden or stone offerings he wishes, made from a single piece, or a woven item no larger than what a woman can weave in a single month. White is the colour appropriate to the gods, both in woven items ^{956a} and in general, while dyes should only be used for the trappings of war. The most divine gifts are birds, and pictures that a single painter can complete in one day, and any other offerings should be modelled on offerings of this sort.

956b

Athenian: Since the subdivisions of the city – their number, and what they should be – have been described, and laws relating to business transactions in all of the important matters have been stated as best we can, what remains is to deal with judicial procedures. The first of our law courts should consist of chosen judges, jointly chosen by the defendant and the prosecutor together, and more appropriately referred to as arbitrators rather than judges. The second shall consist of fellow villagers and tribesmen based upon a twelvefold division, before whom cases are to be argued if no decision was reached in the first court. Here the ^{956c} penalty is to be greater, and if the defendant loses at this second trial he is to pay one fifth more than what

was specified in the written action. And if someone challenges the judges and wishes to contest the issue for a third time, he is to bring the case before the selected judges. And if he loses once again, he is to pay one-and-a-half times the assessed penalty. If the prosecutor, having lost the case in the first court, is dissatisfied and goes to the second, he shall receive an additional fifth if he wins the case, and pay the same fraction of the assessed penalty if he loses. And if the parties go to the third court because they don't accept ^{956d} the previous judgements, the defendant, as we said, is to pay one-and-a-half times the penalty if he loses, while the prosecutor is to pay half.

^{956d}

Athenian: The allocation of courts and their composition, and the appointment of staff to support the various boards of officials, the intervals at which each court must sit, the voting procedures and associated adjournments, and any other requirements of this sort relating to judicial practice, such as the prioritisation of cases, compulsory response to questions and attendance at court, and any related matters, have all been dealt with previously, but it ^{956e} is good to repeat what's right two or even three times. However, all of these minor regulations that are easy to devise may be set aside by the older lawgivers, and the young lawgiver should fill in such details. Now, it would be reasonable for courts dealing with private matters to conduct their business in this way. But for those dealing with communal or public matters, and for those which the various officials make use of in managing the business of their own office, numerous sound regulations produced by reasonable men are already in existence in many cities. Drawing on these, our guardian of the law should provide our ^{957a} fledgling constitution with what it requires by making comparisons and corrections, and testing them in experience, until they decide that each of them is adequate for its purpose. Only then, having concluded the process so that they are quite

immutable, should they implement them on a permanent basis.

957b

Athenian: The matter of respectful silence on the part of judges, and its opposite too, and any divergences from general standards of justice, goodness and nobility in other cities, has to an extent been dealt with, although more will be said towards the end. Anyone who intends ^{957c} to be a fair and just judge must look to these matters and study any writings he possesses on the subject. Indeed, of all subjects, the very best at improving the person who learns them are those dealing with laws, provided they are rightly enacted. Were this not the case, our divine and wondrous law would bear its name in vain, a name that is akin to reason.¹¹⁰

957d

Athenian: Furthermore, when it comes to other utterances such as praise or censure of people, delivered in verse or in prose, either in writing or in daily conversation in all our various interactions, with their contentious disputes, or agreements that are often quite futile, the clear test of all these would be the writings of the lawgiver. Possessing their content within himself as a sort of antidote to the other words, the good judge should regulate himself and the city by ensuring ^{957e} the establishment and growth of justice in good people and doing his best to change the ways of the bad people from ignorance, licence, cowardice, and, in short, from any kind of wrongdoing, provided their habit is curable. But in the case of those who are fated to have such habits, then, as has rightly been said so many times before, those judges and their superiors ^{958a} who impose the death penalty as a cure for souls in this condition deserve the praise of the entire city. Once legal cases for the year have finally been adjudicated, laws are required for their implementation as follows. Firstly, the official deciding the case is to assign to whomever wins the case, all of the property of the person who loses, apart from possessions that he needs to

retain. This should be done in each case immediately after the voting, through ^{958b} proclamation by the herald within the hearing of the judges. And if someone fails to settle with the victorious party to their mutual satisfaction by the end of the month following the month of the trial, the judge who decided the case shall, at the behest of the successful party, hand over the property of the person who lost. But if he does not have the resources, and the shortfall is one drachma or more, the person who lost is not to be allowed to take a legal action against anyone else until he has fully paid off his debt to the successful party. Others, ^{958c} however, are fully entitled to take legal action against this debtor. If anyone who has been convicted obstructs the court that convicted him, the judges who have been unjustly obstructed are to bring the offender before the court of the guardians of the law, and, if a person is found guilty, he is to be sentenced to death as a subverter of our city and its laws.

^{958c}

Athenian: To proceed. When a man has been born and reared and has begotten and reared his ^{958d} own children, has engaged reasonably in business affairs, paying compensation when he has wronged another and accepting the same from someone else, and has duly grown old abiding by the laws, the end comes to him in the course of nature. In the case of the dead, male or female, the interpreters are to have the authority to prescribe the appropriate divine observances, to be performed for the gods beneath the earth and those of our realm. There ^{958e} are to be no graves on any land that can be cultivated, whether the tombs be large or small. They are to fill up places where the land is naturally suited for this sole purpose alone, that of receiving and concealing the bodies of the dead, while causing the least disturbance to the living. Where earth, a true mother in these matters, is naturally inclined to provide sustenance to humanity, no one alive or dead is to deprive us living beings of this. They are ^{959a} not to build up a burial mound higher than

what five men can complete in five days, nor erect a standing stone larger than what is needed to accommodate a eulogy on the life of the deceased in four lines of heroic verse. The laying out of the corpse in the house shall, in the first place, be for long enough to establish that the person really is dead, and not just in a swoon. So in general, for most people, the third day would be a reasonable one for carrying out the burial. We need to listen to the lawgiver, especially when he declares that soul ^{959b} is superior to body in every respect, and that, in this very life, what makes each of us what we are is nothing else but soul, while the body is just an apparition that follows each of us around. And it is well said that the bodies of the dead are images of the departed, while the real being of each of us, which is called the immortal soul, departs to render an account to the other gods, as the ancestral law declares – a fearful prospect for the bad, and a heartening ^{959c} one for the good. But not much help can be given to a deceased person. In fact, all of his kindred should have helped him while he was alive to ensure that he lived as just and as holy a life as possible throughout, thus being free after death from retribution in the life that follows this one for any foul misdeeds. Since this is how matters stand, we should never squander our wealth in the belief that this lump of flesh that is being buried is related to ourselves, rather than believing that the real person, the son or brother or whoever else we ^{959d} imagine we are burying amidst great mourning, has left us to journey on and fulfil his own destiny, while we do our duty through measured expenditure upon this, as it were, soulless altar to the gods of the underworld. And it is the lawgiver who would best divine what that appropriate measure is. So let the law be as follows. For someone of the highest property valuation, the measure of expenditure on the entire burial shall not exceed five minae, three ^{959e} minae for the second highest valuation, two for the third and one for the fourth. There are many other duties that the guardian of the

law must perform, and much that he must look after. Not least of these responsibilities is to spend their lives looking after children and adults, and indeed any age group, and, in particular, at anyone's death, a single guardian of the law is to act as a supervisor, whom the relatives of the deceased are to bring in as an overseer. And if the arrangements relating to the deceased are conducted with dignity and measure, this shall count to the guardian's credit, or indeed to his shame if they fall below these standards. The laying out and the other arrangements are to be conducted in accordance with custom concerning such matters, but we should allow freedom to the statesman ^{960a} when he is legislating, as follows. It would be unseemly for him either to enjoin or prohibit weeping for the dead, but laments and loud displays outside the house are to be forbidden. Bearing the corpse along the public roads and crying aloud as they proceed is to be prohibited, and they must be outside the city walls before daybreak. So let these be the regulations concerning matters of this sort, and whoever complies shall incur no penalty, while anyone who disobeys one of the guardians is to be penalised by all of them with a penalty jointly decided by them all. Any further rituals of burial of the dead, and those deeds that bar one ^{960b} from the right of burial for parricide, robbing temples, and everything of that sort, have been dealt with previously through specific laws, and so our legislative task is almost complete. But the completion of anything never consists merely in doing something or acquiring something or establishing something. Only when we have discovered a means of making our production completely safe for all time may we then believe that we have done all that we should have done. Until then, our overall task is incomplete.

^{960b}

Clinias: Yes, you put that very nicely, stranger. But could you please explain the additional point you are now making more clearly?

960c

Athenian: Dear Clinias, many of our ancient utterances have rightly been praised, not least of these are the names we give to the Fates.

Clinias: Specifically?

960d

Athenian: The first of them is Lachesis, the second is Clotho, then Atropos the third saviour of what has been spoken, making the process irreversible. These should provide a city and a constitution not only with health and soundness of its citizens' bodies, but also with lawfulness of their souls, or, more to the point, security for its laws. And it seems evident to me that this is what our laws are still lacking. They require some natural means of engendering this quality of irreversibility.

Clinias: If it really proves impossible to find some means of imparting this quality to every law, that is no small matter.

960e

Athenian: But it is indeed possible, as I can now see quite plainly.

Clinias: Well, we mustn't let up at all until we have provided the laws we have formulated with this very quality. For it is ridiculous to labour in vain at any task by not building upon secure foundations.

Athenian: You are right to encourage me, and you will find me of the same mind as yourself.

Clinias: Well said. So, what, according to you, would be the salvation of our constitution and our laws, and how would this operate?

Athenian: Well, didn't we say there should be a council in our city, constituted as follows. The ^{961a} ten most senior current guardians of the law, and all those who have been awarded civic distinctions, are to meet together in council. Furthermore,

those who had travelled abroad to seek out anything worth hearing for the guardianship of the law, and had returned safely home, were to be scrutinised by the members, and on approval deemed worthy to join the council. In addition to these, each member was to bring along one young person over the ^{961b} age of thirty, having first decided for himself that the person was worthy in terms of his nature and upbringing. He was to present him to the other members, and take him on if he was approved by the others. If not, the fact of his nomination was to be kept secret from everyone, and especially from the young person who was rejected. The council was to meet before daybreak when everyone would have most freedom from other responsibilities- ^{961c} ties, private or public. This, I believe, was the sort of description we gave in our previous discussions.

^{961c}

Clinias: It was indeed.

Athenian: Having taken up the discussion of this council once more, I would maintain that if someone were to use this, with all it has to offer, as a sort of anchor of the entire city, it would preserve everything we wish to preserve.

Clinias: How so?

Athenian: Now would be the time for us to display the utmost eagerness in explaining matters correctly.

Clinias: Yes, very much so. Please proceed as you propose.

^{961d}

Athenian: Well, Clinias, we need to discern in everything an appropriate saviour in its various activities. So, in the case of a living creature, for instance, soul and the head are naturally most important in this respect.

Clinias: Again, how so?

Athenian: Surely the excellence of these two ensures the saviour of every creature.

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: By reason being present in the soul in addition to everything else, and sight and hearing being present in the head as well as everything else. In short, reason, and the most sublime senses, combined into a unity, may rightly be called the saviour of any creature.

Clinias: Quite likely.

961e

Athenian: Likely, indeed. But in what respect would reason, combined with the senses, be the 962a saviour of ships in storms or on calm seas? On board ship it is the pilot and the sailors who save themselves and the ship's company by combining their senses with the reason of the pilot. Is this not so?

962a

Clinias: Quite so.

Athenian: Not many examples of this sort are needed then. We might consider for instance military expeditions, or any medical care, and the objective the generals or the physicians should rightly aim at in each case to ensure salvation. For the generals, wouldn't it be victory and domination over the enemy? And for the physicians and their assistants, the provision of health to people's bodies?

Clinias: Of course.

Athenian: Now, if the physician had no understanding of the bodily condition we have just called health, or a general had no understanding of victory, wouldn't it be obvious that they did not possess reason in relation to any of these matters?

962b

Clinias: Indeed, how could they?

Athenian: And what about the city? If someone proved ignorant of the objective at which a statesman should aim, would he, in the first place, deserve to be called a ruler? And secondly, would he be able to save something when he is totally ignorant of its objective?

Clinias: No, how could he?

Athenian: So, if the settlement of this region of ours is now to be concluded, there must, it seems, be some thing within it that first understands the objective we are referring to, the one at which we, as statesmen, are aiming, and secondly how this may be attained, capable too of understanding first and foremost which of the laws give the best advice, and which give the worst, and indeed which people do the same. If any city is bereft of something of this ^{962c} sort, it would hardly be surprising if its lack of reason and awareness led it to act every time in a random manner in all of its affairs.

^{962c}

Clinias: That's true.

Athenian: So in our case, in which particular part of the city or in which of its institutions has provision been made for an adequate safeguard of this sort? Can we say?

Clinias: Not really, stranger, not with any certainty anyway. However, if I were to hazard a guess, this argument of yours seems to me to be indicating the council which you said meets at night.

^{962d}

Athenian: Nicely anticipated, Clinias. This council, as our recent argument indicates, should be possessed of all virtue, the first being a refusal to wander and aim at multiple objectives. It should, rather, focus upon one objective, and direct everything to that as if it were firing darts.

Clinias: Entirely so.

Athenian: So, we are now in a position to understand, not surprisingly, that the laws of various cities are so divergent because the legislators in each city look to all sorts of different objectives. It is no wonder, then, that in many cases the definition of what's just, for some of them, is designed to ensure that certain people rule in the city, whether they happen to be good or bad. For others, it is designed to make themselves wealthy, even if they end up being slaves, while some others are intent upon the free lifestyle. But there are others again ^{962e} who legislate for two objectives together, with an eye to both – freedom for themselves, and dominion over other cities. But the wisest – or so they imagine – pursue all of these objectives, and others like them, with no special respect for any one of them, being unable to say which one the others should look to.

^{963a}

Clinias: In that case, stranger, wasn't the position we adopted some time ago correct? For we said, I believe, that all our laws would look to one objective, and we agreed that this is most correctly called excellence.

^{963b}

Athenian: Yes, we did.

Clinias: And we also stated, I recall, that excellence is fourfold.

Athenian: Very much so.

Clinias: And reason is the leader of all these, to which the other three, and everything else, should look.

Athenian: You are following this admirably, Clinias, so pay attention to what remains. In the case of a pilot, a physician or a general, that single objective to which reason should look has been stated. And now at this stage we are examining the reason of the statesman. So, as if we were putting a question to some person, we might ask, "I wonder, my friend, what your gaze is fixed upon. What precisely is that one objective? The reason of

the physician is able to provide a clear answer, so what about you, who might claim to be superior? Are you unable to answer?" Well, Megillus and Clinias, can you speak on his behalf, providing a ^{963c} definition, just as I have given you definitions so often on behalf of others, and tell me what precisely you say this objective is?

^{963c}

Clinias: Not at all, stranger.

Athenian: What is it that we should be eager to discern, both in itself and in what forms?

Clinias: What do you mean by its forms?

Athenian: For instance, when we say that there are four forms of excellence, it is obvious that we must be stating that each, individually, is one.

Clinias: Indeed.

^{963d}

Athenian: And, indeed, we refer to them all as one, as though they were in reality not many but just this one thing, excellence. For we say that courage is excellence, and wisdom is excellence, and so are the other two.

Clinias: Very much so.

Athenian: Well, it is not difficult to say how these two differ from one another and have acquired two names, as have the others. However, it is still no easy matter to explain why we call them both, and the others too, by one name, excellence.

Clinias: How do you mean?

Athenian: It is not difficult to explain my meaning. Let's divide the roles of questioner and answerer between us.

Clinias: Again, what do you mean?

^{963e}

Athenian: You are to ask me why exactly we refer to them both as one thing, excellence, and then again say that there are two things, courage and wisdom. I shall tell you the reason. It is because one of them, namely courage, involves fear, and even wild beasts have a share in this one, and so does the behaviour even of very young children. For the soul can become courageous in the course of nature without reasoning. However, in the absence of reasoning, no soul ever is, has been, or will be wise and possessed of reason. That's the difference.

Clinias: True.

964a

Athenian: Well, you have now received an account from me explaining the way in which they differ and are two. You should now give me an account, in return, of the way in which they are the same and are one. Bear in mind that you will also have to tell me how, although they are four, they are also one. And once you have shown how they are one, you must ask me in turn how they are four. After that, we should consider someone who has an adequate knowledge of anything at all which has a name, and, what's more, also possesses an account. Could he possess knowledge only of the name while being ignorant of the account? Or would it be a disgrace for anyone of any consequence to be ignorant of everything of this sort when dealing with the most important and exalted matters?

964b

Clinias: Apparently so.

Athenian: For a legislator or guardian of the law, or someone who thinks that he is superior to everyone else in terms of excellence, and has been rewarded for such achievements, is there anything of greater importance than these very qualities we are now discussing – courage, sound-mindedness, justice and wisdom?

964c

Clinias: No, how could there be?

Athenian: Then, consider the interpreters, teachers and lawgivers, the very guardians of everyone else in relation to these matters. What if someone lacked understanding and knowledge, or needed to be punished or rebuked for certain transgressions? Shouldn't the one who can teach him the power of evil and excellence, and who can explain this comprehensively, be preferred to anyone else? Or could some poet who has just arrived in the city, or someone claiming to be an educator of the young, prove himself superior to a person who has triumphed in all excellence? Tell me this, then. In a city like that, where there are no guardians competent in word and deed, with an adequate understanding of excellence, would it be surprising if such a city, devoid of guardianship, suffered the fate experienced by so many cities nowadays?

Clinias: No, probably not.

Athenian: Well then, are we to do what we are now suggesting, or what? Are we to provide our guardians, in word and in deed, with a greater perfection in excellence than everyone else? Or how else will our city resemble the head and the senses of wise folk who have acquired an internal guardianship of this sort?

964d

Clinias: How, stranger, are we to understand this likeness, and in what does this consist?

Athenian: The city itself is, of course, the torso of the body, and at the very top, so to speak, are the young guardians who have been selected because they are especially gifted. And being thoroughly quickwitted, they survey the entire city, and as they watch they commit whatever they observe to memory and act as sources of information for the elders on every aspect of civic affairs. These elders, who are likened to reason for their exceptional wisdom in so many matters of importance, are to

deliberate, and using the younger members as assistants ^{964e} and advisers, they co-operate together, acting as true saviours of the whole city. Is this how we say things should be, or should we make some other arrangements? Are all our citizens to have a similar upbringing and education, with no one receiving a more exacting education than anyone else?

^{964e}

Clinias: Heavens, no. That's impossible.

Athenian: Then we should move on to an education that is more rigorous than previously described.

^{965a}

Clinias: Probably.

Athenian: Could the education we began to touch upon just now turn out to be the one we have need of?

Clinias: Yes, indeed.

Athenian: Didn't we say that the supreme craftsman or guardian in any sphere must have the ability not alone to look towards multiplicity, but also to press on to recognise the one, and, having recognised that, to arrange everything else while keeping the one in view?

^{965b}

Clinias: And we were right to say so.

Athenian: Now, could anyone get a more exact vision and perspective in relation to anything, without being able to look from multiplicity and dissimilarity towards one form?

^{965c}

Clinias: Probably not.

Athenian: It is not probable, my friend. It really is the case that no method more certain than this is available to any of us humans.

^{965d}

Clinias: I believe you, stranger, and I do agree. So, we should proceed to discuss the matter in these terms.

Athenian: So, it seems that we must compel the guardians of our divine constitution too, first and foremost, to discern with precision whatever is the same through all four of these, being one and the same in courage, in sound-mindedness, in justice and in wisdom, and rightly called according to us by one name, excellence. To this, my friends, we must if you please hold fast, and not let go until we have stated adequately what precisely it is that we should look to. Is it one, is it a whole, is it both? Or what exactly is it by nature? Or if this evades ^{965e} us, do we think we shall ever properly understand anything about excellence, when we will be unable to say whether it is multiple or fourfold or one? So, if we are to heed our own advice, we shall arrange somehow or other that this knowledge is present in our city. But we also need to decide whether or not to abandon the entire consideration.

^{965e}

Clinias: By the god of strangers, stranger, the last thing we should do is to abandon such a consideration, since you seem to us to be making perfect sense. But how might all this be arranged?

^{966a}

Athenian: We are not yet in a position to say how we should arrange this. We should first ascertain, by agreement among ourselves, whether this consideration is necessary or not.

Clinias: Why, yes it is, provided this can actually be done.

Athenian: Well then, what about the fair and the good? Are we to adopt the same view? Should our guardians recognise only that each of these is multiple, or should they also know how and in what respect each is one?

Clinias: It seems more or less essential that they should also understand how each is one.

966b

Athenian: Well, although they understand this, might they be incapable of demonstrating their understanding verbally?

Clinias: Impossible. You are describing the condition of some slave.

Athenian: And does the same argument of ours apply to all matters of importance? Must those who really are to act as guardians set over the laws really understand the truth about them and be capable of expounding them verbally, and adhering to them in practice, judging what actions are noble by nature, and what actions are not?

Clinias: Of course.

966c

Athenian: Now, one of the most exalted matters, one that we dealt with seriously already, is the subject of the gods. It is important to know, as far as humanly possible, that the gods exist, and the obvious extent of their supreme power. And although we may forgive most of our population if they adhere merely to the letter of the law, we should exclude, even from candidacy as a guardian, anyone who does not work hard at acquiring total faith in the existence of the gods. And this exclusion involves never selecting someone as a guardian of the law ^{966d} who is not divine and who has not worked hard in that direction, and is not even included among those who are recognised for their excellence.

966d

Clinias: Yes, as you say, it is only right that someone who is reluctant or unable to engage with such matters should be kept well away from the ranks of the good.

Athenian: Now, do we know of two factors leading to belief in the gods, among those we described previously?

Clinias: Which two?

966e

Athenian: One was our statement about the soul, when we said that soul is the most ancient and most divine of all things, whose motion once it gets underway provides ever-flowing existence. The other one concerns the regular movement of the stars and other bodies under the control of reason, which has brought order to the universe. For no one, beholding all this with an attentive and trained eye, has ever turned out to be an ungodly person, affected in 967a the way that most people expect. Quite the contrary. In fact, it is commonly believed that those who study such matters are rendered ungodly by astronomy and the other related sciences, through observing events that occur by strict necessity rather than by the intention of a will concerned with accomplishing good.

967a

Clinias: And what is the actual situation?

Athenian: Well, as I said, the situation nowadays is the reverse of what it was when those who consider these bodies thought that they were soulless. Yet, even in those days a sense of wonder crept in, and people who studied them in detail suspected the truth of the view, now 967b held, that if these were devoid of soul they could never have employed such wonderfully accurate calculations, since they would not have possessed reason. And some people, even then, dared to suggest this very doctrine, and say that it is reason that brings order to everything in the heavens.¹¹¹ But these same thinkers fell into error once again by thinking that soul, which is older than body, is in fact younger, and they, so to speak, overthrow everything again, and more to the point, overthrow themselves. For based upon the evidence of 967c their eyes, everything moving in the

heavens seemed to them to be composed of earth and stone and many other soulless bodies, even though these constitute the causes of the entire universe. These views led at the time to constant charges of atheism against such thinkers, and great unpopularity too, and indeed the poets took to slandering those who engage in philosophy by comparing them to dogs howling at the moon and saying other silly things. But nowadays, as I said, the situation is the complete opposite.

967c

Clinias: In what way?

Athenian: It is not possible for any of us mortal humans ever to attain constant reverence for the gods, unless the person understands these two statements: that in the realm of things that come to birth, soul is the oldest, is immortal, and is indeed the ruler of all material bodies.

967d

Athenian: Furthermore, he should understand the statement repeated so often, that reason, belonging to things that are, is present among the heavenly bodies. And he should also understand the necessary subjects that precede these, and having observed their connection with music, apply this in a fitting manner to the practical regulation of human behaviour. And in cases where an explanation is possible, he should be able to give the appropriate account. But ^{967e} whoever is unable to master all this, in addition to the commonplace excellences of the populace, would never be up to the task of ruling the whole city, and should instead assist others in that function. Well, Megillus and Clinias, we should now consider whether, in addition to all the laws we have described already, we should also add this law making legal provision for the Nocturnal Council of rulers, with the special education we have described, to act as a guardian and protector. Or how should we proceed?

968a

Clinias: Of course we must make this addition, my friend, if we are up to the task of doing so at all.

Athenian: In that case, let us, one and all, strive towards this objective. I shall be your eager assistant because of my considerable experience in such matters, and extensive study, although ^{968b} I may find other collaborators.

^{968b}

Clinias: Well, stranger, this is the way that the god is leading us, so this certainly is how we should proceed. But we should now discuss and explore the correct approach to be adopted here.

^{968c}

Athenian: It is not yet possible, Megillus and Clinias, to legislate on such matters. Only when the council has been set up should we pass laws concerning the extent of their authority. At this stage, these arrangements can only be made, if they are to be made correctly, through instruction combined with constant application.

Clinias: In what way? What do you mean by this?

Athenian: First, of course, a list of names is to be drawn up of those who are of a suitable age, learning ability, character and habits for the role of guardian. Subsequent to this it is not ^{968d} easy to discover what subjects should be learned, or to become a pupil of someone else who has discovered them. What's more, it would be futile to specify in writing the sequence in which the various subjects should be taken up, or the duration of the study. Indeed, it would not become evident, even to the very people who are learning them, what it is appropriate to learn until knowledge of what is being learned somehow arises within the soul of each. Accordingly, while it would hardly be right to say that none of these matters is capable of verbal expression, they certainly cannot be formulated in advance, since advance formulation clarifies nothing of what they

contain.

968e

Clinias: In that case, stranger, since this is how matters stand, how should we proceed?

Athenian: Well, my friends, we are, it seems, in the middle with the crowd, as the saying goes, and since we are prepared to take risks with the entire constitution – that the dice may, as 969a they say, turn up a triple six or three ones – that's what we should do. I shall share the danger with you by stating and elaborating my own views on education and upbringing, which have now been set in train once more by our discussion. But the danger is quite significant and quite beyond comparison. So I encourage you, Clinias, to attend to this at least. For once you have established the city of the Magnesians, or whoever else the god names it after, fame will be yours if you establish this in the right way, or at the very least you shall inevitably get a reputation for courage, unparalleled among subsequent generations.

969b

Athenian: If this divine council of ours comes into existence, my dear companions, the city must be entrusted to its care, and there will be hardly any dispute at all on this matter from any modern lawgiver. Then we shall attain the finished waking reality of the dream we dealt with a while ago in our discussion, when we somehow constructed an image depicting the co-operation of reason and the head. For once our members have been meticulously 969c selected, educated as they should be, and then installed in the National Acropolis, they would prove to be guardians like none we have ever seen before in our lives for their excellence as protectors.

969c

Megillus: My dear Clinias, based upon all that has been said, we must either bid farewell to the idea of founding the city, or else

retain the services of this stranger here, by entreaty or any means at our disposal, and make him co-operate with us in the foundation of the city.

969d

Clinias: Very true, Megillus. I shall do as you ask and you should assist me.

Megillus: Assist you I will.

NOTES

1. Odyssey xix.178-179. Minos was the legendary king of Crete, son of Zeus and Europa, who, every nine years, made King Aegeus select fourteen children (seven girls and seven boys) to be devoured by the Minotaur.
2. The goddess referred to here is Athena, the goddess of wisdom and foundress of the city of Athens.
3. Tyrtaeus was an elegiac poet who lived in Sparta. He was noted for his poetry, which exhorted the Spartans to fight courageously in defence of their city. The Athenian stranger quotes the first line of the poem and paraphrases the subsequent nine lines.
4. Theognis was a lyric poet. Despite what the Athenian stranger says here, he is likely to have hailed from the Megara near Athens rather than the Megara in Sicily. His poetry was lively, and provided practical advice about life and commentary on civic matters.
5. According to tradition, Lycurgus and Minos established the Spartan and Cretan constitutions.
6. Plutus, the god and personification of wealth, was, in some contexts, depicted as being blind so that he could distribute his benefits without prejudice.
7. An official group of young Spartan citizens who were tasked with ensuring the compliance of the slaves (helots).
8. Ganymede was kidnapped and taken to Olympus to serve as Zeus' cup-bearer, etc. Iliad xx.231 ff.
9. Dionysus was the god of wine and fertility. Festivals in his honour typically involved liberal consumption of wine.
10. A Cadmeian victory is one that comes at a greater loss than the benefit it brings. It is a proverbial saying that references Cadmus, the legendary founder of Thebes. It is comparable to our phrase 'Pyrrhic victory'.
11. Epimenides was a legendary seer who was granted the power of prophecy after having slept for 57 years in a sacred cave on Crete. Clinias' description puts his birth about a century after its actual date.
12. Wordplay based on an alleged connection, likely fanciful, between the Greek words for 'chorus' and 'joy'.
13. Isis was a goddess in the Egyptian pantheon. She was the sister of Osiris, and it was believed that she assisted the dead in their transition to the afterlife.

14. Cinyras and Midas were legendary kings of ancient kingdoms in Cyprus and Phrygia, respectively.
15. The lines quoted here are from the elegiac poet Tyrtaeus.
16. This is a reference to the story of Cadmus.
17. Cadmus was said to have slain a sacred dragon whose teeth, when planted, grew into a group of fully armed fierce warriors known as the Spartoi.
18. The god of healing.
19. Orpheus was a legendary poet, musician and prophet.
20. Euripides, *Cyclops* 3.
21. This refers to the legendary flood in the age of Deucalion. He and his wife Pyrrha were the only survivors.
22. Daedalus was an inventor and master craftsman who constructed the Labyrinth for King Minos of Crete; Orpheus was a legendary musician and prophet; Palamedes was a prince from Euboea, credited with inventing, among other things, mathematics and writing; Marsyas and Olympus were both musicians who played the doublepipe (aulos); Amphion was a brilliant lyre player.
23. Epimenides was a Cretan seer to whom many magical happenings were attributed.
24. The 'cycle' referred to here is the period of time between cataclysmic events.
25. *Odyssey* ix.112-115, Lattimore.
26. *Iliad* xx.216-218, Lattimore. Dardanus, an ancestor of the Trojan kings, ruled the entire Troad. His grandson Tros gave his name to Troy and the Trojans. Ilium was more commonly known as Troy.
27. The first city is a dynasty, the second is an aristocracy, the third city is in the plains, exemplified by Troy. The fourth, which will be described presently, is a league of cities.
28. Ninos was the legendary founder of the Assyrian Empire, an important kingdom in the Upper Tigris region in modern-day Iraq.
29. The 'Great King' always referred to the King of the Persian empire.
30. According to the *Iliad* (v.640-651), Heracles sacked Troy a generation prior to the Trojan War.

31. Menelaus, king of Sparta and Agamemnon, king of Mycenae, who were both leaders of the second expedition against Troy.

32. Hippolytus was falsely accused by Phaedra, his stepmother, of attempting to sexually assault her. Her husband, Theseus, believed her accusations and cursed his son, asking the sea god Poseidon to kill him. Poseidon sent a bull from the sea, which terrified the horses pulling Hippolytus' chariot. He became entangled in their reins and was dragged to his death.

33. The allusion here is to a short portion of a poem by Pindar, of which only a small fragment remains (Fragment 109, Snell).

34. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 40.

35. The first kings of Sparta were Procles and Erythraeus, twin sons of Aristodemus.

36. This refers to Lycurgus, founder of the Spartan Council of Elders.

37. 'Third saviour' was a proverbial phrase arising from the custom of offering the third libation at banquets to Zeus the Saviour.

38. A group of five overseers who were elected annually by the Assembly (all Spartan citizens were eligible) and who had judicial, financial and administrative powers over the kings and the senators.

39. Sparta had two royal families, both claiming descent from Heracles. The two kings were political, military and religious figures.

40. 'The portion belonging to Aristodemus' is a reference to Sparta.

41. The reference here is to Messene.

42. Cyrus the Great, having become king of a small kingdom in Persia, extended the territory considerably, by conquest and in so doing founded the Persian (Achaemenid) Empire.

43. The reign of Cambyses, Cyrus' son, was marred by military defeats. His successor, his son Darius, was able to steady the ship of state through sensible policies.

44. This expression denotes an education in extreme luxury.

45. Gomates, the Eunuch, seized Cambyses' kingdom for a short time by impersonating his dead brother while Cambyses was away in Egypt.

46. After seven months, Gomates was slain by seven Persian nobles, one of whom was Darius.

47. Datis was the commander of the first Persian expedition. He was sent to punish the island of Eretria, north of Athens, for taking part, along with

Athens, in the revolt against Persian domination in Ionia.

48. Paeans are hymns in honour of Apollo, and the dithyramb is a choral ode to Dionysos.

49. *Nomos* (meaning law, custom, tradition) also refers to a style of song with a prescribed *harmonia* (tuning) and a definite rhythm.

50. The Titans, the older generation of gods, were the first-born children of Uranus and Gaia. The Titans were overthrown by their children, the Olympian gods.

51. Eighty stades is about 14.8 kilometres (9.25 miles).

52. A quotation from Alcman, a Spartan poet.

53. Minos, who had a powerful navy, attacked Athens because his son, Androgeos, had been killed there. He forced the Athenians to send an annual tribute of seven young men and seven young women as food for the minotaur, a half-bull, half-human creature.

54. *Iliad*, xiv.96-102, Lattimore.

55. The Battle of Marathon decided the outcome of the first Persian War; the Battle of Plataea decided that of the second. Both were Greek victories.

56. Nestor, the king of Pylos in the south-western corner of the Peloponnese, was the oldest of the heroes who fought in the Trojan War.

57. A restatement of the concept of philosopher kings from the *Republic* v.473d and *Seventh Epistle* 326b.

58. *Odyssey* xvii.218.

59. The reference here is to Protagoras, an influential sophist, who was famous for having said that man is the measure of all things. His relativist doctrine is described in the *Theaetetus*. He has an eponymous dialogue.

60. This refers to the Pythagorean lists of opposites, which include odd/even, good/bad, right/left, male/female, among others.

61. Nemesis was the goddess of retribution. She resented anyone who violated the natural order of things or possessed a given quality in excess.

62. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 287-292, Lamb.

63. There is a play on the Greek word *nomos* here, which can refer either to a musical melody, tune or strain, or to a law or custom.

64. There is an untranslatable play here upon the word *nomos*, which refers both to a musical melody, tune or strain, and to a law.

65. The Heraclids were the Dorians who controlled Argos, Messene and Sparta.
66. 5,040 is divisible by all numbers from one to ten, but not by eleven. It is divisible by a total of fifty-nine numbers.
67. These three sites all housed influential oracles. Delphi was dedicated to Apollo, Dodona to Zeus, both situated on mainland Greece; the third was dedicated to the Egyptian god Ammon, and located at the oasis of Siwa in the Libyan desert.
68. The division of the 5,040 citizens into twelve yields tribes of 420 people. These smaller tribes can then be further subdivided.
69. A deme was a collection of villages and their inhabitants.
70. The Helots were a large class of subjugated people in ancient Sparta. They substantially outnumbered the Spartans, who were constantly concerned with how to prevent Helot uprisings.
71. The Mariandyni were a people who lived in the region of Bithynia in the north-west of Asia Minor who were enslaved for a time by the inhabitants of Heraclea Pontica, the chief city of the region.
72. *Odyssey* xvii.322 ff, Lattimore.
73. The source of this quote is unknown.
74. The gifts referred to here are grains.
75. The Orphics, whose practices were based on the writings attributed to the legendary poet Orpheus, refrained from killing and eating meat on the basis of their belief in the reincarnation of souls, both of humans and of animals.
76. This is the first mention of these women.
77. Eileithyia was the goddess of childbirth and midwifery.
78. The Corybantes, offspring of the god Apollo, were legendary armed and crested dancers who worshipped the goddess Cybele (Rhea) through their ritual dancing and drumming. Corybantic conditions were pathological compulsions to dance, thought to have been caused by divine possession.
79. Geryon and Briareus were, according to myth, two fearsome many-limbed giants.
80. The techniques referred to here are dropping to the floor in the case of wrestling, and the use of gloves in the case of boxing.
81. The curetes were the Corybantic dancers on Crete who worshipped Rhea, and were said to have protected the infant Zeus.

- 82.** The 'Virgin Queen' of Athens was Athena.
- 83.** A play on the word *nomes*, which can mean either 'laws' or 'melodies' or 'chants'. Here the word is translated as 'measures' in an attempt to reflect this ambiguity.
- 84.** *Odyssey* iii.26-28, Lattimore.
- 85.** A reference to Athena.
- 86.** Thamyras was a mythical singer who challenged the Muses to a competition and lost. Orpheus was legendary for his ability to charm any living thing, and even non-living things like rocks, with his sweet music.
- 87.** One Greek stade was roughly equivalent to 180 metres (600 feet). So a distance of sixty stades is 10.8km (6.75 miles) and a distance of one hundred stades is 18km (11.25 miles).
- 88.** The pancration was a form of combat that combined wrestling and boxing, but also allowed kicking and choking. It was not dissimilar to contemporary mixed martial arts.
- 89.** Laius was a legendary king of Thebes who kidnapped and raped Chrysippus, the young son of King Pelops. As a result of this incident, Laius is cited as having instituted the practice of homosexual pederastic love.
- 90.** Oedipus was said to have married his mother, and Thyestes was said to have raped his own daughter in an attempt to fulfill a prophecy.
- 91.** Iccus of Tarentum was an athlete who was noted for his strict adherence to Pythagorean tenets in his training regime, which included maintaining a meagre diet and abstaining from sexual activity.
- 92.** This was a common expression indicating a resistance to social change.
- 93.** A reference to the autumnal equinox.
- 94.** Lycurgus was the legendary lawgiver who is credited with having established the laws of Sparta, introducing equality among the citizens along with the austere regime of fitness and military preparedness for which Sparta was famous. Solon was a poet and the most famous Athenian lawgiver.
- 95.** This refers back to 863c-d where ignorance as a cause of transgressions is divided into simple and complex forms. The latter is further subdivided into complex ignorance accompanied by power, and complex ignorance accompanied by weakness. Thus, there are three forms of ignorance leading to transgressive behaviour, which, when added to the first two, yield five.

96. That is, in the case of one who kills by his own hand.
97. City officials were to be assessed for their conduct at the end of their terms in office.
98. This statement has been attributed to Thales, who was one of the first of the early Greek philosophers.
99. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 304.
100. *Odyssey* xix.43, Bury.
101. *Iliad* ix.500.
102. The details of this administrative body are discussed later. See 961 ff.
103. The reference here is to Solon.
104. The two are Solon and the lawgiver for the society they are establishing in Magnesia.
105. Epilepsy was known as the 'sacred disease' on account of its presumed connection with the divine.
106. One drachma was equivalent to six obols, thus making the interest on the arrears in a case such as this equal to 200% per year.
107. In the *Iliad*, Patroclus was killed by Hector while wearing the armour of his companion, Achilles. *Iliad* xvii.125 ff, xviii.78 ff.
108. According to legend, Caeneus was originally a woman, Caenis, who was transformed into an invincible man by Poseidon at her request.
109. This is a reference to the Nocturnal Council. For further details, see 960b ff.
110. A connection is made here between the words *nomos* (law) and *nous* (reason).
111. This is likely to be a reference to the preSocratic philosopher Anaxagoras, whose influence upon Socrates is described in Plato's *Phaedo*.

Lysis

ΛΥΣΙΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

HIPPOTHALES a young man

CTESIPPUS a cousin of Menexenus

LYSIS early teens

MENEXENUS early teens

scene: a newly erected palaestra (wrestling school) outside the west wall of Athens

203a

Socrates: I was making my way from the Academy directly to the Lyceum,¹ along the road outside the wall, under the wall itself. But when I reached the gate at the spring of Panops, I came across Hippothales there, the son of Hieronymus, along with Ctesippus of Paeania, and there were other young men with them standing together in a group. And when Hippothales saw me approaching, he said,

Hippothales: “Socrates, where are you going, and where have you come from?”

203b

Socrates: “From the Academy,” said I. “I am making my way directly to the Lyceum.”

Hippothales: “Come here,” he said, “directly to us. Will you not join us? It will be well worth your while.”

Socrates: “Where do you mean,” I asked, “and whom should I join?”

Hippothales: “Here,” he replied, showing me an enclosure of sorts with its door open, just opposite the wall. “Here is where we spend our time, ourselves and others, a great many others, handsome too.”

204a

Socrates: “But what is this, and what do you spend your time doing?”

Hippothales: “It is a wrestling school,” he replied, “newly built. But we spend our time for the most part in discussions, and we would be most pleased to include you in them.”

Socrates: “It is good of you to do so,” said I. “But who does the teaching here?”

Hippothales: “A friend of yours,” said he, “and an admirer, Miccus.”

Socrates: “By Zeus,” said I, “he is no ordinary man, at any rate. No, he is a competent man of wisdom.”

Hippothales: “So, would you like to follow us,” he said, “and see for yourself who is here?”

204b

Socrates: “I would first like to hear what I am going in for, and who the handsome one is.”

Hippothales: “There are differing opinions on that, Socrates.”

Socrates: “Tell me, who you think it is, Hippothales?”

Socrates: When he was asked this question, he blushed, and I said, “Son of Hieronymus, Hippothales, there is no need to say whether you are in love with someone or not, for I know that you are not only in love but also that you are already proceeding far along love’s path. I myself am, for the most part, quite ordinary and useless, but somehow or other, God has given me the ability to recognise quickly a lover and a beloved.”

204d

Socrates: Now, when he heard this, he blushed even more, much more. So Ctesippus² said,

Ctesippus: “It is so charming, Hippothales, that you blush and are shy about telling Socrates the name. But if the man spends

any time with you, even a little, he will be worn out by hearing you mention the name so often. At any rate, Socrates, he has deafened our ears by filling them up with 'Lysis'. And if he has been drinking, there is a good chance we will be woken from our slumbers thinking we are hearing the name Lysis. Now, what he says in normal conversation is awful, but it is not really awful compared to the times when he tries to pour his poems all over us, and his prose compositions too. And what is even more awful than all this is when he sings to his favourite, in an extraordinary voice, which we have to endure hearing. And now, when you ask him for the name, he blushes!"

204e

Socrates: "It seems that Lysis is a young man," said I. "I say this, because when I heard the name I did not recognise it."

Ctesippus: "Yes," he replied, "he does not use his own name very much. He is still named after his father, because his father is so very well known. But I know full well that you will not fail to recognise the boy's appearance. Yes, he is sufficiently recognisable from his appearance alone."

Socrates: "Tell me whose son he is," said I.

Ctesippus: "He is the eldest son of Democrates of Aexone," he replied.

205a

Socrates: "Well, Hippothales," said I, "what an utterly noble and spirited love you have discovered. Come on then, show to me what you also show to these people here so that I may see whether you know what a lover should say about his favourite, either to him directly, or to others."

Hippothales: "Socrates," said he, "do you attach any significance to anything this fellow is saying?"

Socrates: "Well," said I, "do you even deny being in love with the one this fellow is referring to?"

Hippothales: “I do not,” he replied, “but I deny composing poems for my favourite, and prose works too.”

Ctesippus: “The man is not well,” said Ctesippus. “No, he is raving, and quite mad.”

205b

Socrates: And I said, “Hippothales, I am not asking to hear any of the verses, or any ode you may have composed to the young man, but I do want to hear what your thinking is, so that I may know how you behave towards your favourite.”

Hippothales: “Surely this fellow here will tell you,” said he, “since he knows and remembers in such detail, if indeed, as he claims, he is deaf listening to me.”

Ctesippus: “By the gods,” said Ctesippus, “I certainly am, and what he says is actually ridiculous, Socrates. Indeed, how can a lover avoid being ridiculous when he is so preoccupied with his favourite he has nothing of his own to say that even a child would not say? So, what he puts into verse and prose is whatever the whole city celebrates about Democrates, and Lysis, the boy’s grandfather, and about all his ancestors – their wealth, the horses they bred, and their victories, in the Pythian, Nemean, and Isthmian games,³ with four-horse chariots or single horses, and stories still more ancient than these. Indeed, the other day, in some poem or other, he recounted a connection with Heracles and how an ancestor of theirs entertained Heracles as a guest because they were related, the ancestor himself being the offspring of Zeus and the daughter of the founder of their deme. What the man says and sings, and forces us to listen to, are the stories of old women, Socrates, and there are many more like these.”

205e

Socrates: And when I heard this I said, “You are ridiculous, Hippothales! Are you composing a victory ode to yourself

before you have won the victory?”

Hippothales: “No, Socrates, I am not composing or singing it to myself.”

Socrates: “You do not think so, at any rate,” said I.

Hippothales: “So, what is going on?” he asked.

Socrates: “These odes apply most of all to you,” said I, “for if, on the one hand, you capture a favourite who is like this, all that you have said and sung is an adornment to you, and is in reality a victory ode to you, as though you had been victorious because you were successful with a favourite like this one. But if, on the other hand, he escapes you, the more you have said in praise of that favourite, the more nobility and goodness will you seem to be losing, and the more ridiculous will you look. So whoever is wise in matters of love, my friend, does not praise the beloved until he captures him for fear of how events may unfold. And besides, whenever anyone praises those handsome fellows and makes much of them, they get full of ideas about themselves, and become arrogant. Don’t you think so?”

Hippothales: “I do,” he replied.

Socrates: “Don’t they become harder to capture as they become more arrogant?”

Hippothales: “Quite likely.”

Socrates: “Well, what sort of hunter do you think would rouse his quarry in the course of the hunt, and make it harder to capture?”

Hippothales: “A bad one, of course.”

206b

Socrates: “And indeed, it is most uncivilised to use speech and song in order to make someone wild rather than to soothe them. Is this so?”

Hippothales: “It seems so to me.”

Socrates: “Be careful, Hippothales, that you do not render yourself liable to all these allegations because of your poetry. What is more, I do not think you would be prepared to accept that a man who does harm to himself with his poetry is ever a good poet, insofar as he is harmful to himself.”

206c

Hippothales: “By Zeus, no,” said he. “That would be highly irrational. But, Socrates, these are the very reasons why I am confiding in you, and if you have anything else to offer please advise me as to what a person should say or do if he is to be regarded with affection by his favourite.”

Socrates: “It is not easy to say,” I replied. “But if you are prepared to get him to enter into a discussion with me, perhaps I may be able to show you what you should say when you converse with him instead of saying what, according to these people, you actually say and sing.”

206d

Hippothales: “Well, that is no problem,” he said, “for if you go inside along with Ctesippus here, sit down and converse, I think he will surely come over to you, Socrates, since he is particularly fond of listening to discussions, and besides, as they are celebrating the festival of Hermes, the older boys and the younger ones are mingling with one another. So he will come over to you, and if he does not, he is friendly with Ctesippus through Ctesippus’ cousin, Menexenus,⁴ and, in fact, Menexenus happens to be his companion, more so than anyone else. So Ctesippus should call him if he does not come over himself.”

206e

Socrates: “That is what we should do then,” said I. And with that, I took Ctesippus with me and went over to the wrestling school, and the others followed us. When we arrived inside, we

found that the boys had offered the sacrifice, and the associated rituals had almost been completed by then, so they were all playing knucklebones, dressed in their finery. Now, although most of them were playing outside in the courtyard, some were playing odds-and-evens in a corner of the dressing room, with a huge quantity of knucklebones which they were picking from some little baskets, while others stood around watching them. In fact, one of them was Lysis, and he was standing among the boys and youths, wearing a garland on his head, most distinctive in his appearance, worthy of note not just for his beauty, but because he is both beautiful and good.

207a

Socrates: We, for our part, withdrew to the opposite side because it was quiet there, and we sat down and were discussing something with one another. Now, Lysis kept turning around to look at us, and he was obviously eager to come over, but he was at a loss for a while and was reluctant to come over on his own. Then Menexenus entered from the courtyard, between games, and once he saw myself and Ctesippus he came to sit beside us. So, when Lysis saw him he followed suit and sat with us too, along with Menexenus. Then the others came over, and what is more, when Hippothales saw so many people standing there, he used them as a screen and stood close by where he thought Lysis could not see him because he was afraid of annoying him, and he stood like that and listened.

207b

Socrates: I then looked over at Menexenus and asked, “Son of Demophon, which of you is older?”

Menexenus: “We argue over that,” he replied.

Socrates: “Then you would also dispute over which of you is more noble,” said I.

Menexenus: “Very much so,” he replied.

Socrates: “And, likewise, over which of you is more handsome.” They both laughed at that. “However, I will not ask which of you is more wealthy, since you are friends, aren’t you?”

Menexenus: “Very much so,” they replied.

Socrates: “Well, it is said that friends have all things in common, so you will not differ on this issue at any rate, if what you say about your friendship is actually true.”

207c

Socrates: They both agreed. After that, as I was in the process of asking which of them was more just or more wise, someone came in and fetched Menexenus away, saying that the trainer was calling him. I presumed he was involved in conducting a sacrifice. So he went out, and I asked Lysis a question: “Presumably,” said I, “your father and mother love you very much, Lysis?”

Lysis: “Certainly,” he replied.

Socrates: “In that case, they would want you to be as happy as you could possibly be?”

Lysis: “Of course.”

207d

Socrates: “Do you think that a person who is enslaved, and who is not allowed to do any of the things he desires is happy?”

Lysis: “By Zeus, I do not think so,” he said.

Socrates: “Well, if your father and mother love you and desire that you become happy, it is obvious that they are eager, in every way, that you should be happy.”

Lysis: “Of course,” he said.

Socrates: “So, do they allow you to do whatever you wish, and do they not rebuke you at all or prevent you from doing whatever you desire to do?”

Lysis: “By Zeus, Socrates, there are lots of things they stop me from doing.”

207e

Socrates: “What do you mean?” I asked. “Although they want you to be happy, they prevent you from doing what you wish? Tell me this: if you developed a desire to ride on one of your father’s chariots, taking the reins during a race, they would not allow you to do so. They would prevent you, wouldn’t they?”

Lysis: “By Zeus, they certainly would not allow me.”

Socrates: “Whom would they allow to do it?”

Lysis: “There is a driver who is paid by my father.”

Socrates: “What do you mean? Do they trust a hireling more than they trust you to do whatever he wishes with the horses, and as well as this they pay him money?”

Lysis: “What else could they do?” said he.

208c

Socrates: “But I presume they would trust you to take charge of the mule-team, and if you wished to grab the whip and beat them, they would allow you to do so.”

Lysis: “Why ever would they allow me?” he replied.

Socrates: “Well, then,” said I, “is no one permitted to beat them?”

Lysis: “Of course,” he replied, “the muleteer.”

Socrates: “Is he a slave or a free man?”

Lysis: “A slave,” he replied.

Socrates: “Then it seems they think more highly of a slave than they do of you, their own son, and they trust him with their own property, rather than you, and they allow him to do whatever he wishes, yet they prevent you from doing so. But tell me this

too: do they allow you yourself to be in charge of yourself, or do they not even trust you in this?"

Lysis: "How could they trust me in this?"

Socrates: "Is someone in charge of you then?"

Lysis: "This tutor here," he replied.

Socrates: "Surely he isn't a slave?"

Lysis: "What else would he be? He is ours though," he said.

Socrates: "How awful," said I, "a slave in charge of a free man. But what does this tutor do when he is in charge of you?"

Lysis: "Well, he takes me to my teacher," said he.

208d

Socrates: "Surely they are not in charge of you too, your teachers I mean."

Lysis: "Entirely so."

Socrates: "So, your father, of his own free will, puts a whole host of masters and rulers in charge of you. But when you get home to your mother, does she allow you to do whatever you wish with her wool or her loom, when she is weaving, in order to make you happy? Yes, I presume of course that she does not prevent you from touching the blade or the shuttle or any other part of her wool-spinning equipment."

208e

Lysis: He laughed at this and said, "Socrates, not only would she prevent me, but she would beat me if I were to touch them."

Socrates: "By Heracles," said I, "surely you have not wronged your father and your mother somehow?"

Lysis: "By Zeus, I have not," he replied.

Socrates: "Then, for what reason do they prevent you, so cruelly, from being happy and doing whatever you wish,

bringing you up all day long in constant slavery to someone and, in a word, doing scarcely anything you desire? Consequently, it seems you do not even benefit from their extensive wealth. No, everyone else exercises more control over it than you do. Nor do you benefit from your own body, noble and all as it is, but someone else cares for it and shepherds it. But you are in charge of nobody, Lysis, nor do you do anything you desire.”

209a

Lysis: “That is because I am not yet of age, Socrates.”

Socrates: “Son of Democrates, that should not stop you, since there are areas where your father and mother do place trust in you and do not wait until you are of age. Indeed, when they want someone to read to them or to do some writing, I presume you are the first person in the house to whom they assign this task. Is this so?”

Lysis: “Very much so,” said he.

209b

Socrates: “Therefore, in these cases you are allowed to write the letters of the alphabet in any sequence you wish, and you are allowed to read with the same degree of freedom. And when you take up the lyre, I am sure that neither your father nor your mother prevent you from tightening and loosening any of the strings you wish, or from plucking it or using the plectrum. Do they prevent you?”

Lysis: “Of course not.”

209c

Socrates: “Well then, Lysis, what exactly is the reason why they do not prevent you in these cases, yet in the other cases we mentioned just now they do stop you?”

Lysis: “I think it is because I know about these, but I do not know about the others.”

Socrates: “That is it, my good man,” said I. “So your father is not waiting for your coming of age before he trusts you in everything. But when he thinks you understand better than he does, on that day he will entrust himself and his possessions to you.”

Lysis: “Yes, I think so,” he replied.

209d

Socrates: “Very well,” said I, “and what about your neighbour? Do you think he will use the same rule in dealing with you as your father does? Do you think he will entrust the management of his own household to you whenever he believes you understand the management of household affairs better than he understands them himself, or might he take charge of it himself?”

Lysis: “I think he would entrust it to me.”

Socrates: “What about the Athenians? Don’t you think they would entrust their affairs to you once they noticed that you have enough understanding?”

Lysis: “I think they will.”

Socrates: “By Zeus,” said I, “what about the Great King? Would he trust his eldest son, who is to be ruler of all Asia, to throw anything he wishes to throw into the stew when the meat is being boiled, rather than us, if we were to present ourselves before him and show him that we had a more refined understanding of food preparation than his own son?”

Lysis: “Obviously, he would trust us,” he replied.

209e

Socrates: “And although he would not allow his son to throw anything into the pot, he would even allow us to throw in handfuls of salt if we wished.”

Lysis: “Yes, of course.”

Socrates: “And what if his son’s eyes were diseased? Would he allow him to touch his own eyes if he did not think he was medically qualified, or would he stop him?”

Lysis: “He would stop him.”

Socrates: “But if he presumed that we had medical skills, and if we wished to open his son’s eyes and sprinkle them with ashes, I think he would not stop us, as he would assume we had the appropriate level of understanding.”

Lysis: “That is true.”

Socrates: “So, would he also entrust to us, rather than to himself and his son, all other matters in which we seemed to him to be wiser than the two of them?”

Lysis: “Necessarily, Socrates,” he replied.

210a

Socrates: “So that is how things are, dear Lysis,” said I. “Everyone, Greeks and non-Greeks, men and women, will entrust us with matters we understand. And in these cases we shall do whatever we wish, and nobody will deliberately obstruct us, and we shall be free in ourselves and have charge of others, and these will be ours, for we shall benefit from them.

210b

Socrates: “But in matters in which we have not acquired intelligence, no one will entrust these to us to do whatever we think we should do. Instead, everyone will obstruct us to the best of their ability, not just strangers, but our father, and mother, and any kindred even closer than these, and we ourselves shall be subject to others in these matters. And these will be alien to us, for we shall derive no benefit from them. Do you accept that this is the case?”

Lysis: “I do.”

Socrates: “So shall we be dear to anyone, and will anyone love us, in these matters wherein we are of no benefit?”

Lysis: “Of course not.”

210c

Socrates: “In that case, your father, does not love you, nor does anyone love any other person in so far as that person is useless.”

Lysis: “It seems not,” he replied.

210d

Socrates: “So, if you actually become wise, everyone will love you, and everyone will be your kindred, for you will be useful and good. But if you do not, neither your father nor anyone else will love you, nor will your mother, nor your kinfolk. Well, Lysis, is it possible under these circumstances to have an enlarged understanding, in matters one does not yet understand?”

Lysis: “How could we?” he replied.

Socrates: “Now, if you are in need of a teacher, you do not yet understand.”

Lysis: “True.”

Socrates: “So you do not have an enlarged understanding, if, in fact, you still lack understanding.”

Lysis: “By Zeus, Socrates, I do not think so.”

210e

Socrates: When I heard this, I looked over at Hippothales and almost made a mistake, for it occurred to me to say, “Hippothales, that is how you should converse with your favourite, humbling him and deflating him rather than puffing him up and spoiling him as you do.” But when I saw him struggling and in tribulation over what was being said, I remembered that he had actually stood where he hoped Lysis

would not notice him. So I checked myself and held my words back. Meanwhile, Menexenus had returned and was sitting beside Lysis in the seat he had vacated earlier. Then Lysis, unnoticed by Menexenus, whispered to me playfully in a low, friendly voice.

Lysis: “Socrates, say what you have been saying to me to Menexenus too.”

Socrates: And I said, “You shall say that to him, Lysis, since you have been paying such full attention.”

Lysis: “I certainly have,” he said.

211b

Socrates: “Then try to remember it as best you can,” I said, “so that you can tell him everything comprehensively. And if you forget any of it, ask me again when you next meet me.”

Lysis: “Yes, I shall do that, Socrates. I am very keen to do so, rest assured. But say something else to him, Socrates, so that I can listen to that too, until it is time to go home.”

Socrates: “Well, that is what I should do,” said I, “since you are the one who is asking. But be sure to come to my aid if Menexenus attempts to refute me. You know how argumentative he is, don’t you?”

211c

Lysis: “Yes, by Zeus,” said he, “very much so. That is the very reason why I want you to converse with him.”

Socrates: “So that I can look ridiculous?” said I.

Lysis: “No, by Zeus, so that you can punish him.”

Socrates: “How so?” said I. “That is not easy, since the man is formidable, a pupil of Ctesippus’. And look, can’t you see? Ctesippus is here in person.”

Lysis: “Do not be concerned about anyone else, Socrates,” said he. “Just go ahead and converse with him.”

Socrates: “Converse I must,” said I. Now, as we were saying all this Ctesippus interrupted, and asked,

211d

Ctesippus: “Why are you holding a feast just for two? Won’t you share your discussions with us?”

Socrates: “Of course, we should share them,” said I. “This fellow does not understand something I am saying, but he says that he thinks Menexenus knows, and he is asking me to question him.”

Ctesippus: “Well,” said he, “why not question him?”

Socrates: “I shall ask him then,” I replied. “And you, Menexenus, should answer the questions I ask you. The fact is that from my childhood I have had a desire for a particular possession, just like anyone else. But the difference is that while one person has a desire to acquire horses, another to acquire dogs, another to acquire gold, and another to acquire honour, I am easy about all these. However, when it comes to the acquisition of friends, I am extremely passionate, and I would rather have a good friend than the best quail or cockerel anyone ever had. Yes, by Zeus, rather than any horse or dog either, and I think, by the dog, that I would far sooner acquire a companion than all of Darius’ gold, or even Darius himself.⁵ That is how fond of companions I am.

212a

Socrates: “So, seeing the two of you, yourself and Lysis, I am amazed, and I account you blessed, because you are able to acquire this possession quickly and easily at such a young age. Indeed, you have acquired this man, such a staunch friend, so quickly, and he, for his part, has got you. But I am so far from acquiring this that I do not even know how one person becomes the friend of another. And since you are experienced, these are

the very issues on which I wish to question you.

212b

Socrates: “Tell me then, when someone loves someone else, which of them becomes a friend? Does the one who loves become the friend of the one who is loved, or does the one who is loved become the friend of the one who loves, or is there no difference?”

Menexenus: “I think there is no difference,” he replied.

Socrates: “What do you mean?” said I. “Do they both become friends of each other if only one of them loves the other?”

Menexenus: “I think so, anyway,” said he.

Socrates: “What about this? Isn’t it possible for someone who loves not to be loved in return by the person he loves?”

Menexenus: “It is.”

212c

Socrates: “And what about this? Is it also possible for someone who loves to be hated? This is the sort of fate, I imagine, that lovers sometimes seem to suffer in dealing with their favourites. For although they love them as much as they possibly could, some believe that they are not loved in return, others that they are hated. Don’t you think this is true?”

Menexenus: “Yes,” he replied, “very true.”

Socrates: “Well,” said I, “in a case like this, doesn’t one person love, while another is loved?”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “So which of them is the friend of which? Is the one who loves a friend of the one who is loved, whether or not he is loved in return, or even if he is hated? Or is the one who is loved the friend of the one who loves? Or again, in a case like this, is neither of them a friend of the other unless they both love one

another?”

Menexenus: “Well, yes, that seems to be how matters stand.”

212d

Socrates: “So, this seems different to us now than it seemed previously. Yes, it seemed to us then that if one loved, both were friends. But now, unless both love, neither is a friend.”

Menexenus: “Maybe so.”

Socrates: “So nothing that does not love in return is a friend to the one who loves.”

Menexenus: “It seems not.”

Socrates: “So there are no horse-lovers unless the horses love them in return, nor quail-lovers either. Nor again are there dog-lovers, wine-lovers, exercise-lovers, nor any lovers of wisdom unless wisdom loves them in return. Or do they each love these things even though these are not friends, and was that poet a liar who said, ‘Happy is he who has children as friends, solid hoofed horses too, / Dogs that he hunts with, and a host when he travels abroad.’⁶

Menexenus: “I do not think so,” he replied.

Socrates: “Then you think he was speaking the truth.”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

212e

Socrates: “So, Menexenus, that which is loved is, it seems, a friend to the one who loves it, whether it loves him or indeed hates him. For instance, children recently born who have not yet begun to love, and can even demonstrate hatred, even though they hate their mother or father when they are punished by them, are nevertheless at that very moment, above all, the very dearest of friends to their parents.”

213a

Menexenus: “I think,” he said, “that is so.”

Socrates: “So, based on this argument, the one who is loved is a friend, but not the one who loves.”

Menexenus: “So it seems.”

Socrates: “And the one who is hated is an enemy, but not the one who hates.”

Menexenus: “Apparently.”

213b

Socrates: “In that case, lots of people are loved by their enemies and hated by their friends. And they are friends to their enemies and enemies to their friends, if the one who is loved is a friend, but not the one who loves. Yet it is most illogical, my dear friend – in fact, I think it is impossible – to be an enemy to a friend, or a friend to an enemy.”

Menexenus: “You seem to be speaking the truth, Socrates.”

Socrates: “Well then, if this is impossible, then that which loves would be a friend of that which is loved.”

Menexenus: “Apparently.”

Socrates: “Then again, that which hates would be an enemy of that which is hated.”

Menexenus: “It must be.”

213c

Socrates: “In that case, it will prove necessary to accept the same propositions we accepted earlier. A friend is often a friend of a non-friend, or even of an enemy, in cases where someone either loves that which does not love him, or even loves that which hates him. And an enemy is often an enemy of a non-enemy, or even of a friend, in cases where someone either hates that which does not hate him, or even hates that which loves him.”

Menexenus: “Quite likely,” said he.

Socrates: “Well now, what are we going to do,” said I, “if those who love are not to be friends, nor are those who are loved, nor are those who love and are also loved? Shall we say that there are still some further cases besides these where people become friends with one another?”

Menexenus: “No, by Zeus, Socrates, I cannot really see a way out of this difficulty.”

213d

Socrates: “Well,” said I, “perhaps we have not been conducting the enquiry in the proper manner at all, Menexenus.”

Lysis: “Well, that is how it seems to me, Socrates,” said Lysis, and as soon as he had said this he blushed. In fact, I think his words got out unintentionally because he was paying such close attention to what was being said. Indeed, it was evident that he had listened intently throughout.

213e

Socrates: Now, I wanted to give Menexenus a rest, and I was delighted by Lysis’ love of wisdom, so I changed my approach, directed my words to Lysis, and said, “Lysis, I think that what you are saying is true, that if we had been considering the matter properly we would never have wandered about like this. So let us not go in this direction any longer, for the enquiry looks difficult to me, rather like a hard road. No, I think we should go back to where we turned off and consider the matter based on what the poets say, for these people are like our fathers in wisdom, and our guides. They speak, of course, in no ordinary manner when they hold forth on the subject of friends and who they actually are. But they do maintain that god himself makes them friends by drawing them towards one another. And what they say I believe goes somewhat as follows: ‘God doth ever draw like unto like’,⁷ and he makes them

acquainted. Or have you not come across these verses?"

Lysis: "I have," he replied.

Socrates: "Haven't you also come across the writings of extremely wise people making the same point, that like is necessarily always friend to like? These, I presume, are the people who discourse and write about nature and the universe."

Lysis: "That is true," said he.

Socrates: "Well, then," said I, "are they right to say so?"

Lysis: "Perhaps," he replied.

214c

Socrates: "Perhaps it is half right," said I, "and perhaps it is entirely right. But we do not understand it, since it seems to us that the more a bad person gets closer to another bad person, and the more he associates with him, the more he becomes his enemy. For he acts unjustly, and it is presumably impossible for those who act unjustly, and those whom they treat unjustly, to be friends. Isn't this so?"

Lysis: "Yes," said he.

Socrates: "Accordingly, one half of their statement would not be true, if bad people are indeed like one another."

Lysis: "That is true."

214d

Socrates: "But I think they mean that the good people are like one another and they are friends, while the bad people, as the saying goes, are never alike. They are not even like themselves, since they are impulsive and unstable. And whatever is unlike and different from itself could hardly be like something else or be its friend. Is that what you think too?"

Lysis: "I do," he said.

Socrates: “Then it seems to me, my friend, that this is the riddle posed by those who say that like is friend to like: that the good person alone is friend to the good person alone, while the bad person never attains true friendship with either the good or the bad. Is that how it seems to you too?”

Socrates: He nodded.

214e

Socrates: “So, at this stage, we have the answer. We know who the friends are, for the argument is indicating that they are the people who are good.”

Lysis: “Well, it certainly seems so to me,” he said.

Socrates: “And to me,” I said. “And yet, there is something in it that is bothering me. Come on then, by Zeus, let us look at what I am suspicious about. Is the like person, insofar as he is like, a friend to his like, and is such a person useful to the other person? Or let me rather put it as follows. What benefit would anything that is like anything else be able to afford to its like, and what harm could it do that it could not also afford or do to itself? Or what could be done to it that it could not also do to itself? Indeed, how could such things as these be prized by one another if they offer no assistance to one another? Is there any way?”

Lysis: “There is not.”

Socrates: “And how could that which is not prized be a friend?”

Lysis: “There is no way it could.”

215a

Socrates: “In that case, a like person is not a friend to his like, while the good person – to the extent that he is good, not to the extent that he is like – would be a friend to a good person.”

Lysis: “Perhaps.”

Socrates: “What about this? Wouldn’t the good person, to the extent that he is good, be sufficient unto himself, to that extent?”

Lysis: “Yes.”

Socrates: “And the person who is sufficient, based upon his sufficiency, lacks nothing?”

Lysis: “Of course.”

Socrates: “And the person who does not lack anything would not prize anything either?”

Lysis: “No, he would not.”

Socrates: “And what he did not prize, he would not love either?”

Lysis: “Of course not.”

Socrates: “And he who does not love is not a friend?”

Lysis: “Apparently not.”

215b

Socrates: “So, can we say that good people will be friends to good people at all when they do not long for one another when they are apart, since they are sufficient unto themselves even whilst apart, nor do they have any need of each other when both are present? Is there any way that such people as these might set much value on one another?”

Lysis: “There is not,” said he.

215c

Socrates: “And yet, they would not be friends if they did not set much value on themselves.”

Lysis: “True.”

Socrates: “Just take note, Lysis, of how we are going wrong. Could it be that we are, in a sense, being totally misled?”

Lysis: “In what way?” he asked.

Socrates: “There once was a time when I heard someone say, and I am only recollecting it now, that like is utterly hostile to like, and so are good people to good people. What is more, he brought in Hesiod as his witness, by quoting him as follows: ‘And potter is angry with potter, / Bard with bard and beggar with beggar.’⁸

215d

Socrates: “And then he said that this necessarily applies in all other cases, that things that are most like one another are filled with envy, contention and hatred towards one another, while those that are most unlike are filled with friendship. Indeed, for the sake of the assistance that is offered, the poor man is necessarily a friend to the wealthy man, the weak man to the strong, and the sick person to the physician, and anyone who lacks knowledge prizes the one who knows, and loves him.

215e

Socrates: “He then went on, pressing his point in a loftier style, claiming that like was in no way friend to like, and that the situation was the exact opposite since the complete opposite is friend, most of all, to the complete opposite. For according to him that is the sort of thing that anything desires, rather than its like. So dry desires moist, cold desires hot, bitter desires sweet, sharp desires dull, empty desires fullness, and full desires emptiness, and the same argument applies to any other cases. For the opposite is food for its opposite, while the like derives no benefit from its like. And, indeed, my friend, as he said all this he also seemed quite clever because he spoke so well. But what do you both think of what he says?” I asked.

216a

Menexenus: “Well,” said Menexenus, “it sounds good when I hear it like that.”

Socrates: “So, should we declare that the opposite is friend, most of all, to its opposite?”

Menexenus: “Entirely so.”

216b

Socrates: “Well,” said I, “isn’t this absurd, Menexenus, and won’t those all-round wise men, the disputatious folk, attack us gleefully and ask us if enmity is the exact opposite of friendship? What reply shall we give them? Or isn’t it necessary for us to agree that they are speaking the truth?”

Menexenus: “It is necessary.”

Socrates: “In that case, they will ask is the enemy friend to the friend, or is the friend friend to the enemy?”

Menexenus: “Neither,” he replied.

Socrates: “But is the just friend to the unjust, or the sound-minded to the unrestrained, or the good to the bad?”

Menexenus: “No, I do not think that is the case.”

Socrates: “And yet,” said I, “if one thing is indeed friend to another, insofar as they are opposites, it is also necessary that these be friends.”

Menexenus: “It is necessary.”

Socrates: “So like is not friend to like, nor is opposite friend to opposite.”

Menexenus: “It seems not.”

216c

Socrates: “But let us also consider this. Perhaps the friend is evading us to an even greater extent because it is, in truth, none of these. Rather, that which is neither good nor bad becomes a friend of the good, on that very basis.”

Menexenus: “What do you mean?” he asked.

216d

Socrates: “Well, by Zeus,” said I, “I do not know. The fact is I am getting dizzy due to the perplexity involved in this argument, and there is every chance that ‘the beautiful is friend’, as the old proverb says. It seems somehow to be something soft, smooth and slippery, and that is probably why it slips away and eludes us, because that is the sort of thing it is. Indeed, I am saying that the good is beautiful. Don’t you think so too?”

Menexenus: “I do.”

216e

Socrates: “Then I say, prophetically, the neither good nor bad is a friend of the beautiful and the good. Listen now as I explain what my prophecy relates to. It seems to me as though there are three kinds of things: the good, the bad, and the neither good nor bad. What do you think?”

Menexenus: “I think so too,” he replied.

Socrates: “And the good is not friend to the good, nor the bad to the bad, nor the good to the bad. Our previous argument would not allow this either. So, if anything is actually friend to anything else, what is left, the neither good nor bad, is friend either of the good, or of whatever is like itself. For nothing would, I presume, become friend to the bad.”

Menexenus: “True.”

Socrates: “Nor, as we said just now, would like become friend to like. Is this so?”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “So that which is like the neither good nor bad, will not be a friend to whatever is like itself.”

Menexenus: “Apparently not.”

217a

Socrates: “So, it turns out that the neither good nor bad alone is friend to the good alone.”

Menexenus: “That seems necessary.”

Socrates: “Well then, boys,” said I, “is what we are now saying also leading us in the right direction? Well, consider the healthy body if you like. It has no need of medical treatment or the associated benefits, for it is healthy enough already. So no one who is healthy is friend to a physician, because he is healthy. Is there anyone?”

Menexenus: “There is no one.”

Socrates: “But the person who is sick is, I imagine, a friend because he is ill.”

Menexenus: “Of course.”

217b

Socrates: “Now, illness is bad, while medical treatment is beneficial and good.”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “But a body, insofar as it is a body, is presumably neither good nor bad.”

Menexenus: “Quite so.”

Socrates: “And yet a body is compelled by disease to embrace and to love medical treatment.”

Menexenus: “I think so.”

Socrates: “So the neither good nor bad becomes a friend of the good, because of the presence of bad.”

Menexenus: “So it seems.”

217c

Socrates: “This obviously happens before it, itself, becomes bad because of the bad that it has. And of course, once it has become

bad, it would no longer have any desire for the good, nor be its friend. For we said it is impossible for bad to be a friend of good.”

Menexenus: “Yes, impossible.”

Socrates: “Now, consider what I am saying. I say that some things are themselves like those that are present with them, while others are not. For instance, if someone decided to besmear anything at all with some colour, the smeared colour is presumably present to whatever it is smeared onto.”

Menexenus: “Certainly.”

217d

Socrates: “Well then, in respect of colour, is the smeared object at that stage of the same kind as what is on it?”

Menexenus: “I do not understand,” said he.

Socrates: “Consider this,” I said. “If someone were to smear your blonde hair with white lead, would it then be white or would it appear white?”

Menexenus: “It would appear white,” said he.

Socrates: “And whiteness would actually be present to it.”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “Nevertheless, it would be no more white than it was before, and despite the presence of whiteness it is not white, or black either.”

Menexenus: “True.”

217e

Socrates: “But of course, my friend, once old age brings on this same colour, your hair then becomes like in kind to what is present, white by the presence of white.”

Menexenus: “Of course.”

Socrates: “Well, this is what I am now asking you. Will something that has something else present to it be like in kind to that which is present, or does this depend upon the manner of its presence?”

Menexenus: “It is more the latter,” said he.

Socrates: “And so the neither good nor bad is, on occasion, not yet bad although bad is present, but there are times when it has already become like the bad.”

Menexenus: “Entirely so.”

218a

Socrates: “In that case, whenever it is not yet bad, even though bad is present, this particular presence makes it desire good, but once it makes it bad, it deprives it of that desire, and at the same time of the friendship of the good. For it is no longer the neither good nor bad, but bad, and we said bad is not friend to good.”

Menexenus: “It is not.”

Socrates: “Accordingly, we should also say that those who are wise already no longer engage in philosophy, whether they are gods or human beings. Then again, we should say that those who are in such an ignorant condition as to be bad people do not engage in philosophy, for no one who is bad and ignorant engages in philosophy. So we are left with those who possess this bad thing, ignorance, but are not yet rendered senseless by it, or ignorant, even though they still think that they know what they do not know. It follows then that those who are not yet either good or bad engage in philosophy, while those who are bad do not, nor do those who are good. For it was evident to us, in our earlier discussions, that opposite is not a friend of opposite, nor like of like. Don’t you remember?”

218b

Menexenus: “Entirely so,” they both replied.

218c

Socrates: “In that case, Lysis and Menexenus,” I said, “we have now discovered, comprehensively, what the friend is and what it is not. Indeed, we declare that whether it is based upon the soul, or based upon the body, or anything else, the neither good nor bad is a friend of the good, because of the presence of bad.”

Socrates: They both said that they agreed completely that this is the case. And what is more, I myself was utterly delighted, like a hunter pleased at having what I was hunting for within my grasp. And then, I don’t know from where, the strangest suspicion came over me that what we were accepting might not be true. And I was suddenly quite agitated, and I said, “Oh dear, Lysis and Menexenus, it looks as if our new found wealth is only a dream.”

218d

Menexenus: “But why?” asked Menexenus.

Socrates: “I am afraid,” said I, “we may have met up with some arguments concerning the friend that are quite like pretentious people.”

Menexenus: “How so?” he asked.

Socrates: “Let us consider it in this way,” said I. “Would someone who is a friend be a friend to something, or would he not?”

Menexenus: “He must be,” he replied.

Socrates: “Would he be a friend for the sake of nothing and because of nothing, or for the sake of something and because of something?”

Menexenus: “For the sake of something and because of something.”

Socrates: “Now, consider that ‘something’ for the sake of which a friend is friend to his friend. Is that a friend, or is it neither friend nor foe?”

218e

Menexenus: “I do not entirely follow,” he replied.

Socrates: “That is reasonable enough,” said I, “but here is something you will perhaps follow, and I think that I too will better understand what I am saying. We said just now that someone who is ill is a friend of the physician. Isn’t this so?”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “In that case, isn’t he a friend of the physician because of disease and for the sake of health?”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “And yet, sickness is a bad thing?”

Menexenus: “Of course.”

Socrates: “What about health?” said I. “Is it a good thing or a bad thing, or neither?”

Menexenus: “A good thing,” said he.

219a

Socrates: “So, we were saying, it seems, that the body, being neither good nor bad, is a friend of medical treatment because of disease, that is because of something bad even though medical treatment is something good. But it is for the sake of health that medical treatment has acquired this friendship, and health is a good thing. Is this so?”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “And is health a friend or not a friend?”

Menexenus: “A friend.”

Socrates: “And disease is a foe?”

Menexenus: “Very much so.”

Socrates: “So, the neither bad nor good is a friend of the good because of the bad, that is the foe, for the sake of the good, that is the friend.”

Menexenus: “Apparently.”

Socrates: “So the friend is a friend for the sake of the friend, because of the foe.”

Menexenus: “So it seems.”

219b

Socrates: “So be it,” said I. “Since we have arrived at this point, boys, we should pay close attention lest we be deceived. I am prepared to allow that a friend has become the friend of the friend, and the like becomes a friend of the like, something we say is impossible. Nevertheless, there is a point we should consider in case what we are now saying does deceive us. We are saying that medical treatment is a friend for the sake of health.”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “Isn’t health also a friend?”

Menexenus: “Entirely so.”

Socrates: “So, if it is a friend, it is a friend for the sake of something?”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “For the sake indeed of some friend, if it is actually to be in conformity with what was agreed previously.”

Menexenus: “Entirely so.”

219c

Socrates: “Won’t that in turn also be a friend, for the sake of a friend?”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “Well then, if we go on like this, mustn’t we necessarily either exhaust ourselves or arrive at some beginning which will no longer refer to another friend, but will have come to that which is first friend, for the sake of which, we say, all the others are friends.”

Menexenus: “Necessarily.”

Socrates: “Now, this is what I mean. All the others which we said are friends for the sake of that are indeed so many images of it, and should not deceive us, since that friend is the first, the one that is, in truth, friend.

219d

Socrates: “Let us think about it like this. Whenever someone sets great value on something, as a father for instance sometimes esteems his son above all his other acquisitions, does a man like this, for the sake of holding his son in high regard, also set great value upon something else? For example, if he was aware that his son had drunk hemlock, wouldn’t he set a great value on wine, if he thought it would save his son?”

Menexenus: “Of course,” he replied.

Socrates: “And also on the vessel that contained the wine?”

Menexenus: “Entirely so.”

219e

Socrates: “Well then, in that moment does he set no greater value on his own son than on a clay cup, or on three measures of wine than on his own son? Or is the situation as follows: all concern of this sort is directed not to whatever is provided for the sake of something else, but to that for the sake of which anything of this sort is provided. We often say that we set great value upon gold and silver. I am not denying this, but that does not make the statement any truer. But we do value, most of all, that for the sake of which gold, and everything that is provided, is provided, whatever it proves to be. Shall we put it like that?”

Menexenus: “Certainly.”

220b

Socrates: “Doesn’t the same argument apply to the friend? Indeed, when we speak of those who are friends to us, for the sake of some other friend, we are obviously saying it using the mere word ‘friend’. But the actual friend is likely to be the very one in which all these so-called friendships end up.”

Menexenus: “That is quite likely so,” he said.

Socrates: “In that case, the actual friend is not a friend for the sake of a friend.”

Menexenus: “True.”

Socrates: “Well, this idea that a friend is a friend for the sake of a friend is now dismissed. But is the good a friend?”

Menexenus: “I think so.”

220c

Socrates: “So, is it because of the bad that the good is loved, and do matters stand as follows? We have been speaking of three things just now: good, bad, and neither good nor bad. Suppose there were only two left, and the bad were to depart and be gone, and to interact with nothing, neither with body nor soul, nor with anything else that according to us is neither good nor bad just by itself. Would the good then be of no benefit to us? Would it rather have become useless? For if nothing were to harm us any more, we would not be in need of any assistance at all, and accordingly it would become evident that we cherish and love the good because of the bad, the good being a sort of remedy for the bad, and the bad being a sort of disease, and in the absence of disease there is no need for a remedy. So, is the good like this by nature, and is it loved by us because of the bad, we who are midway between the bad and the good? And is it itself of no benefit, for its own sake?”

Menexenus: “That seems to be how matters stand,” he replied.

220e

Socrates: “So that friend to us, the one in which all the others end up – the others that according to us are friends for the sake of another friend – that friend does not resemble these at all. For these are called ‘friends for the sake of a friend’, while the actual friend turns out to be by nature the complete opposite of this, for it proved to be our friend for the sake of a foe, but if the foe departs, this friend it seems is no longer our friend.”

Menexenus: “It seems not,” said he, “based on what is now being said at any rate.”

221a

Socrates: “Well,” said I, “by Zeus, if bad ceases to exist, will there still be hunger or thirst or anything else of that sort? Or will there always be hunger as long as there are humans and other living beings, but will it not be harmful? And thirst too, and the other desires, will these exist but not be bad, since bad has ceased to exist? Or is it ridiculous to ask what will be, or not be, in that situation, for who knows? But in any case, we do know that as matters now stand it is possible to be hungry and be harmed, and it is also possible to be benefited. Is this so?”

Menexenus: “Entirely so.”

221b

Socrates: “Therefore, when someone experiences thirst, or desires anything else of that sort, it is possible sometimes to desire them in a beneficial manner, sometimes in a harmful manner, and sometimes neither?”

Menexenus: “Emphatically so.”

Socrates: “Well, if the bad things cease to exist, is there any reason why it is appropriate for things that are not bad to cease to exist along with them?”

Menexenus: “No reason.”

Socrates: “So desires that are neither good nor bad will exist, even if bad things cease to exist.”

Menexenus: “So it appears.”

Socrates: “Now, is it possible, whilst experiencing desire and passion, not to love whatever the desire and passion is for?”

Menexenus: “I do not think so.”

221c

Socrates: “In that case, even when bad things cease to exist, there will still be some friends.”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “This would not be the case if bad was the cause of something being a friend, since one thing could not be friend to another if this ceased to exist. For once a cause ceases to exist, it is presumably impossible that whatever this cause caused, should still exist.”

Menexenus: “Correct.”

Socrates: “Now, haven’t we agreed that the friend loves something, and does so because of something? And we thought at the time that whatever is neither bad nor good loves the good because of the bad?”

Menexenus: “True.”

Socrates: “But now, it seems, some other cause of loving and being loved is making an appearance.”

Menexenus: “So it seems.”

221d

Socrates: “Well then, is it the case, as we were saying just now, that desire is the cause of friendship, and that which desires is friend to whatever it desires at whatever moment it desires it? And was what we were saying earlier, about what a friend is, just idle chatter, like a tedious, long drawn-out poem?”

Menexenus: “Quite likely,” said he.

Socrates: “And yet,” said I, “that which desires, desires what it lacks. Is this so?”

Menexenus: “Yes.”

Socrates: “So that which is friend, is friend to that which it lacks?”

Menexenus: “I think so.”

Socrates: “And that from which something is taken away, becomes lacking.”

Menexenus: “Of course.”

221e

Socrates: “It seems then that the passion, the friendship and the desire is apparently for that which is kindred to us, Menexenus and Lysis.”

Socrates: They both concurred. “So, if the two of you are friends to one another, you are somehow, by nature, kindred to one another.”

Menexenus: “Exactly,” they said.

222a

Socrates: “And so,” said I, “if one person desires another, my boys, or experiences passion, he would never have felt desire or passion or love unless he somehow happened to be kindred to the object of his passion, on the basis of soul or on the basis of some characteristic, or manners, or form of the soul.”

Menexenus: “Certainly,” said Menexenus, but Lysis was silent.

Socrates: “So there it is,” said I. “It has become evident to us that we necessarily love what is kindred by nature.”

Menexenus: “So it seems,” he said.

Socrates: “Then it is necessary that the genuine and unpretentious lover be loved by his favourite.”

222b

Socrates: To this Lysis and Menexenus gave a somewhat reluctant nod of assent, while Hippothales was so pleased that he turned all sorts of colours. And I, wishing to scrutinise the argument, said, “If what is kindred differs from what is like, we would in my opinion, Lysis and Menexenus, be saying something worthwhile about what a friend is. But if what is kindred and what is like happen to be the same, it is not easy to discard the previous argument, that like is useless to like based upon their likeness, and to accept that what is useless is a friend. Well, since the argument is making us drunk, would you like to come to an agreement and declare that what is kindred is something different from what is like?”

Menexenus: “Certainly.”

222c

Socrates: “And shall we also propose that the good is kindred to everyone while the bad is alien to them all? Or is the bad kindred to the bad, and the good to the good, and the neither good nor bad to the neither good nor bad?”

222d

Socrates: They both said that in their opinion, each is kindred to each, in this way. “Well then, boys,” said I, “we have once more fallen back into those arguments about friendship that we discarded initially. For the unjust will be no less a friend to the unjust, and the bad no less a friend to the bad, than the good will be to the good.”

Menexenus: “So it seems,” he said.

Socrates: “What about this? If we should declare that the good and the kindred are the same, is the good a friend to nothing else but the good alone?”

Menexenus: “Certainly.”

Socrates: “And yet we thought that we ourselves had refuted this argument. Don’t you remember?”

Menexenus: “We remember.”

222e

Socrates: “What use might we still make of this argument? Or is it obvious that there is none? So I should, like the wise men in the law courts, go back over everything that has been said. Indeed, if neither the loved nor the loving, nor those who are like nor those who are unlike, nor the good, nor the kindred, nor any others we have gone through – there were so many that I no longer remember them – well, if none of these is a friend, I no longer have anything to say.”

223a

Socrates: Having said all this, I was thinking of engaging one of the older age group, when the tutors of Menexenus and Lysis came in, like spirits of some sort, bringing the boys’ brothers. They called them, and ordered them to come home since it was already quite late. Now, along with the group around us, we tried initially to drive them away, but when they paid no heed to us, kept on speaking angrily in broken Greek, and calling the boys just as before, we decided they had had too much to drink at the Hermaea festival and might be difficult to deal with, so we gave in to them and broke up our gathering.

223b

Socrates: However, while they were departing, I said, “Now, Lysis and Menexenus, we really have become figures of fun, me an old man, and the two of you. For these people here will say, as they are leaving, that we think we are friends of one another – indeed, I also count myself as one of you – but we have not yet been able to discover what the friend is.”

NOTES

1. The Lyceum was a temple dedicated to Apollo Lyceus, which later became a site for public exercise. It is perhaps best known as the location of Aristotle's Peripatetic school, founded in 334.
2. Ctesippus appears as a character in Plato's *Euthydemus*. He is also mentioned in Plato's *Phaedo* as having been present on the day Socrates was executed.
3. These, together with the Olympic Games, comprised the Panhellenic Games. These were athletic competitions that were held among participants from throughout the Greek world in alternating years of a four-year cycle.
4. Menexenus is mentioned in Plato's *Phaedo* as having been present on the day Socrates was executed. There is also a dialogue of that name attributed to Plato.
5. The reference here is to Darius, King of the Achaemenid Empire of Persia.
6. Solon, Fragment 23, Edmonds.
7. *Odyssey* xvii.218.
8. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 25-26.

Menexenus

ΜΕΝΕΞΕΝΟΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

MENEXENUS of Athens, son of Demophon

scene: unspecified

234a

Socrates: Menexenus, are you coming from the Agora, or from where?

Menexenus: Yes, from the Agora, Socrates, from the Council Chamber in fact.

Socrates: Why exactly were you at the Council Chamber? Or is it obvious that you think you have completed your philosophic education and intend to turn to more important subjects because you believe that you are now up to the task? My wonderful fellow, are you, at your age, turning your hand to exercising authority over us, your elders, so that your house may keep up its tradition of looking after us?

234b

Menexenus: Socrates, if you allow me to assume public office and advise me to do so, I'll be eager, but not otherwise. On this occasion, I went to the Council Chamber because I found out that the Council was about to select someone to speak over the war dead. You know, of course, that they are about to arrange their funeral rites.

Socrates: Certainly, but whom did they select?

Menexenus: No one, they put it off until tomorrow. However, I think that Archinus or Dion will be selected.

234c

Socrates: And, indeed, Menexenus, to die in battle seems to be a noble fate in all sorts of ways. For even if someone dies in poverty, he gets a noble and magnificent burial, and he wins praise although he was an ordinary fellow, praise from wise

men who do not speak at random but in speeches prepared long before. These people utter their praises so well, speaking of qualities each individual possesses and does not possess, using such splendid verbal embellishments that they enchant our souls as they praise the city in all sorts of ways, the war dead too, and our ancestors who went before us, and, indeed, ourselves who are still alive. And so, Menexenus, I myself, when praised by them, am ennobled by them, and every time I listen, spellbound, I believe there and then that I have become greater, nobler and more exalted.

235b

Socrates: And it often happens that some foreigners are regularly present along with me as part of the audience, and suddenly I become more exalted in their eyes. And, indeed, these people seem to be affected in the same way, both in relation to myself, and to the city in general which they believe to be more wonderful than they previously thought it to be, because they are won over by the speaker. This feeling of exaltation remains with me for three days or more, so deeply does the stream of speech and sound from the speaker sink in through my ears. Only with difficulty, in four or five days, do I remember myself and realise that I am here on earth. Until then I just imagine that I am dwelling on the Isles of the Blest, so accomplished are these rhetoricians of ours.

235d

Menexenus: Socrates, you are always mocking the rhetoricians. However, on this occasion, I think that whoever is selected won't be well prepared since the selection has been left very late, and so the speaker will probably be compelled, more or less, to improvise their speech.

Socrates: How could that be so, my good friend? Each of these fellows has speeches already prepared, and, what's more, it is not difficult to improvise such speeches either. Indeed, if

someone had to speak well of Athenians before an audience of Peloponnesians, or of Peloponnesians before Athenians, a good rhetorician would be required who could be persuasive and well respected. But when performing before the very people he is praising, it is no great achievement to seem to speak well.

Menexenus: You think not, Socrates?

Socrates: Indeed not, by Zeus.

Menexenus: Do you think that you yourself could deliver the speech if required, and if the Council selected you?

235e

Socrates: Well, Menexenus, it would be no surprise if I too were able to deliver the speech. I happen to have a teacher of rhetoric who is far from ordinary. In fact, she has produced many a good rhetorician, including one, Pericles, the son of Xanthippus, who surpasses all other Greeks.

Menexenus: Who is she? Or are you obviously referring to Aspasia?

236a

Socrates: Yes I am, and to Connus, the son of Metrobius. For these are my two teachers, he of music, she of rhetoric. It is hardly surprising then that a man, trained in this way, is an accomplished speaker. But even a person who had been less well educated than me, having been taught music by Lamprus or rhetoric by Antiphon of Rhamnous,¹ even he could be well respected when praising Athenians before an audience of Athenians.

Menexenus: And what would you have to say if you were required to speak?

236b

Socrates: Although I probably have nothing of my own to say, I listened yesterday to Aspasia rehearsing a funeral oration about these very people. She had heard what you just reported, that

the Athenians are about to select a speaker. So she went through a speech for me as it should be delivered, partly improvised, partly prepared in advance by cobbling together various parts left over from when she, as I believe, composed the funeral oration that Pericles delivered.

Menexenus: Can you actually remember what Aspasia said?

Socrates: Yes, unless I am mistaken. I learned the speech from her at any rate, and I was lucky to escape being beaten when my memory failed me.

236c

Menexenus: So why don't you run through it?

Socrates: In case my teacher gets angry with me for making her speech public.

Menexenus: No fear of that, Socrates, but speak on and you will please me greatly whether you choose to recite Aspasia's speech or someone else's. Just speak.

Socrates: But perhaps you will laugh at me if you think I am still playing games in my old age.

Menexenus: Not at all, Socrates, just speak anyway.

236d

Socrates: But, of course, you deserve to be gratified, and even if you were to call upon me to undress and dance, I would gratify you since we are alone. So listen, for she spoke, I believe, initially of the dead themselves in the following way.

Socrates: "By our actions, these men have received all that they themselves deserve, possessed of which they proceed on that fated procession, accompanied in community by the city, and in private by their families. But the law also ordains that one remaining honour be bestowed upon them in words, and that's what is now required. For, by a well-delivered speech, remembrance and honour are assured to those who perform

noble deeds, from all who hear of them. What is needed then is a speech that will give sufficient praise to the dead, while gently exhorting the living by calling upon their offspring and brothers to imitate the excellence of such people, and by consoling their mothers and fathers or any of their remaining ancestors who are still alive.

237a

Socrates: “So what sort of speech might portray this for us? Where might we rightly begin our praise of such good men who, whilst living, gladdened their compatriots by their excellence, and, in death, purchased the salvation of the living? I believe we should praise these men in accord with nature and the manner in which they became good. They became good because of their birth from good parents. So we should first praise their noble origins, and then their upbringing and education. After that we shall display the catalogue of their deeds and show how noble these were, and how worthy of their lineage. Their ancestry was primarily responsible for their noble birth. Their descent was not from outsiders, nor did their lineage turn such descendants into mere settlers in this land, mere arrivals from elsewhere. They were, rather, sprung from the very land itself, inhabiting their true fatherland, living there, being reared not by a stepmother like other peoples, but by their own mother; this land in which they dwelt and under which they now lie in death in familiar regions of the land that bore them, nurtured them, and has now received them back again. But it is only right to begin by honouring the mother herself, for in this way it follows that we honour the noble birth of these men at the same time.

237c

Socrates: “Our land is worthy of praise not just by ourselves but by all peoples for all sorts of reasons, but first and foremost because it happens to be beloved of the gods. Proof of our assertion lies in the disputation of the gods about this land, and the associated judgement.² And surely it is only right that all of

us humans should praise the land that the gods praise? The second basis for deserved praise of our land would be that in an age in which the entire earth was productive and brought forth a vast variety of creatures, wild and tame, our land proved to be undefiled, producing no wild animals, but of all creatures it chose to give birth to the human being, who exceeds all others in understanding and who alone believes in justice and the gods. Strong evidence for this assertion lies in the fact that the land has given birth to the ancestors of these people, and to ours too. For anything that gives birth possesses the nutriment needed by its offspring, and by this fact we can see whether a woman is the true birth mother or just a foster mother who lacks the fount of nutriment for the offspring. And our land, our mother, provides evidence enough that she brought forth us humans, for at the time she alone was first to bear human nutriment, food consisting of wheat and barley by which the human race is best and most excellently nourished, proving that she really did bring forth this living being. And it is best to accept evidence of this sort as applicable more to the land than to woman, for in conceiving and giving birth, earth does not imitate woman; no, woman imitates earth. But she did not begrudge this food; rather, she also apportioned it to others. After this she brought forth the olive for her children to help them in their travails. And having nurtured and reared them to adulthood, she brought in gods as their rulers and teachers, whose names we already know, so we should leave these aside for now. The gods equipped us for life by educating us first in skills for use in our daily lives, and also for the defence of our country by teaching us the acquisition and use of arms.

238c

Socrates: “Having been born and educated in this way, the ancestors of these people lived under a civic arrangement, which they framed for themselves and merits a brief mention now. For a civic arrangement is a nurturer of humanity, a good

one of good people, a bad one of bad people. So it is necessary to show that our ancestors were nurtured under a good civic arrangement because of which they were good people, as are the present generation, including the fallen who lie here before us. For this civic arrangement was then, and is now, the rule of the best, under which we live as citizens today, and for the most part always have done since that past era. One person calls this democracy, another names it as they please, but it is, in truth, aristocracy with popular approval. For although we always have kings, these are sometimes hereditary and sometimes selected. Yet, for the most part, the people hold power in the city, and they devolve power and positions of authority to those deemed best at any time, and no one is excluded from power by weakness or poverty or the obscurity of their ancestry, nor are they preferred for the opposite reasons as happens in other cities. There is but one criterion, that whoever is regarded as wise and good exercises power and authority.

238e

Socrates: “Equality of birth is responsible for our civic arrangement. Other cities are constituted from people of all sorts who are not equal, so that their civic arrangements, which are tyrannies and oligarchies, are also unequal. Their inhabitants regard one another in some cases as slaves, in other cases as masters, while we and our kindred, all brothers born of the same mother, do not expect to be slaves or masters of one another. Our natural equality of birth compels us to seek equality under the law, lawfully, and to yield to one another in nothing except a reputation for excellence and wisdom.

239a

Socrates: “As a consequence, the fathers of these people, our fathers too, and the people themselves, all of noble birth, having been reared in total freedom have displayed many noble deeds for all to see, both in private and in public, in the belief that they should fight for freedom with Greeks on behalf of

Greeks, and with non-Greeks on behalf of all Greeks. The story of how they defended their own country when Eumolpus and the Amazons and others before that waged war against it, and how they defended the Argives against the Cadmeans, and the Heraclids against the Argives,³ deserves more time to recount. But their excellence has already been well hymned in verse by the poets and proclaimed to all. So, if we were to attempt to do justice to these same exploits in plain prose, we would probably appear second-rate. That's why I think we should leave them aside, since they have received the praise they deserve. But there are other deeds which still lie forgotten, for which no poet has yet received a reputation worthy of these worthy themes. These, I believe, should be mentioned, praising them and drawing out subjects for others to set down in odes and poetry in general, in a manner worthy of those who performed the deeds.

239d

Socrates: “The first of these occurred when the Persians were in control of Asia and were in the process of enslaving Europe. The children of this land – our parents – withstood them, and it is right and necessary to mention them first and praise their excellence. Now, if anyone is to praise this well, they need to look at it having gone back in time, mentally, to that era when all Asia was already enslaved by the third king. The first of these kings was Cyrus who liberated the Persians, his fellow countrymen, by his own determination. At the same time, he also enslaved the despotic Medes and ruled over the rest of Asia as far as Egypt. His son ruled Egypt, and Libya too, as far as he was able to advance. The third king, Darius, with his land forces, set their boundary as far away as Scythia, and dominated the seas and the islands with his navy so that no one even thought of opposing him. All peoples were mentally enslaved because the Persian Empire had enslaved so many great military nations.

240a

Socrates: “Darius made an accusation against ourselves and the Eritreans. On the pretext that we had plotted against Sardis, he sent 500,000 men in transport ships and battleships along with 300 ships of war. Datis was in command, and Darius told him to return, bringing the Eritreans and Athenians in captivity if he wished to keep his own head. He sailed to Eritrea against men who were among the most famous of the Greeks in warfare at the time, and whose numbers were not small. These he overpowered in three days, and he then conducted a search of their entire territory so that no one would escape him. This is how he did it. Having arrived at the borders of Eretria, his soldiers positioned themselves at intervals from sea to sea. They joined hands and went through the entire region so that they would be able to say to their king that no one could have escaped them. With the same intention, they set sail from Eritrea to Marathon, assuming it would be easy for them to subject the Athenians to the same fate as the Eritreans and place them under the yoke of captivity. Although they had implemented their plans, and their attempted enslavement was underway, no fellow Greeks came to the aid of the Eritreans and the Athenians except for the Spartans, who arrived the day after the battle. All the others were terrified, and they kept quiet, prizing their temporary safety. By placing yourself in their situation, you may realise the sort of men these were in terms of excellence, who took on the might of the non-Greeks at Marathon, chastened the pride of all Asia, and were the very first people to erect a victory trophy over the non-Greeks, thus becoming leaders who taught everyone else that the might of the Persians was not invincible, but that numbers and wealth always yield to excellence. So, I declare that these men were not only the fathers of our physical bodies, but also of freedom for ourselves and for all those who dwell on this continent. Indeed, once they beheld this achievement, the Greeks, as pupils of the

soldiers of Marathon, were emboldened to run the risks involved in the subsequent battles for the sake of our security.

241a

Socrates: “Now, although we must in our speech grant primacy to these people, second place should go to those who were victorious in the naval battles around Salamis and at Artemisium.⁴ There is, of course, much to recount about these men too, and the sorts of onslaughts they endured by land and by sea, and how they defended themselves against these. But I shall also mention what I regard as their supreme achievement, that they completed the next task after the accomplishments at Marathon. For the victors at Marathon only demonstrated to their fellow Greeks that a few of them could defeat many non-Greeks in a land battle. But in a naval battle, the doubt remained, and the Persians were reputed to be invincible by sea because of their numbers, their wealth, their skill and their strength. So of all the achievements of the men who fought the naval battles at the time, what deserves our praise is the fact that they did away with this remaining fear among the Greeks by stopping them from being afraid of large numbers of ships and men. It follows, then, that the rest of the Greeks were educated by the soldiers who fought at Marathon and the sailors who fought at Salamis. They learned the discipline of not fearing the non-Greeks either by land, as taught by one group, or by sea, as taught by the other. But I maintain that, both in rank and in excellence, the action at Plateia for the security of Greece came third, and here at last was a joint endeavour of the Spartans and the Athenians. All these men warded off the greatest and most grievous danger, and we are praising them now for this display of excellence, as will our successors in time to come.

241d

Socrates: “But afterwards, many Greek cities were still aligned with the non-Greeks, and it was reported that the King himself

was planning to make another attempt against the Greeks. It is only right, then, for us to mention those who brought the endeavours of their predecessors for our security to a conclusion by clearing out all the non-Greeks and driving them from our waters. These were the sailors who fought at Eurymedon and the soldiers who waged war against Cyprus, and those who sailed to Egypt and lots of other places. These are people we should mention with gratitude because they forced the King, out of fear, to pay attention to his own security rather than plotting the annihilation of the Greeks.

242a

Socrates: “Now, this war against the non-Greeks was endured to the very end by our entire city, on our own behalf, and on behalf of all Greek speaking peoples. But when peace had come and our city had won respect, we suffered the fate that tends to befall those who are successful. We were the victims first of a general rivalry, and then of jealousy, which drew this city, against its will, into a war against our fellow Greeks. After this, once the war was underway, whilst fighting for the freedom of the Boeotians, we met with the Spartans at Tanagra, and although the battle was indecisive, the subsequent action did decide the matter, for the Spartans withdrew and departed, deserting the very people they were assisting, while on the third day our army won a victory at Oenophyta and justly brought back the people who had been unjustly expelled. These warriors, then, were the first who, after the Persian war, assisted their fellow Greeks against fellow Greeks in the cause of freedom, proved themselves to be good men who liberated those whom they helped, and having been honoured by the city, were the first to be buried here in this tomb.

242c

Socrates: “But subsequent to these events there was an extensive war,⁵ and all the Greeks marched against us and ravaged our territory, treating this city as it ill deserved. Yet

when our troops had defeated them at sea and captured the Spartan leaders at Sphacteria, we could have slaughtered them, but we let them go, sent them back, and made peace, taking the view that we should pursue a war against our fellow Greeks only to the point of victory, and should not do violence to the common fellowship of the Greek peoples because of resentment particular to our own city. However, against non-Greeks, war should, we thought, be pursued to the point of destruction. These men deserve our praise, men who fought in the war and who now lie here, because they proved that if anyone argues that in the previous war – the one against the non-Greeks – any other peoples were superior to the Athenians, that argument is entirely untrue. These men here have proved this by prevailing militarily in the strife amongst the Greeks by getting the better of the leaders of the other Greeks, and by defeating, on their own, the very people alongside whom they had once defeated the non-Greeks.

242e

Socrates: “After the peace, a third war broke out,⁶ terrible and unexpected, in which many good men died, men who lie here. Many fell during the Sicilian campaign whilst fighting for the freedom of the Leontinians. Faithful to their oaths, they sailed to those regions, but because of the length of the journey and because our city was in difficulty and unable to support them, they met with misfortune and abandoned the campaign. But their enemies who fought against them had more praise for the sound-mindedness and excellence of these men than other people have for their own friends. Many others fell in the naval battles at the Hellespont, where they captured the entire enemy fleet in a single day and won numerous other victories.

243a

Socrates: “I said that this war was terrible and unexpected. What I meant was that the other Greek cities became so determined to defeat us that they dared to make

representations to the hated king, whom they had expelled during their alliance with ourselves. They asked him, on their own account, to come back again, non-Greeks leagued against Greeks, thus gathering the united forces of the Greeks and non-Greeks against our city. Here it was that the strength and excellence of our city shone forth. For they believed that we were already worn down by war, and although our navy was under threat in Mytilene, we sent sixty ships to the rescue. Our citizens manned these themselves and proved themselves beyond dispute to be the very best of men by defeating their enemies and liberating their fellows. But they met with undeserved misfortune when their bodies were not taken from the water to lie before us here.⁷ That's why it is necessary to remember these men and to praise them always, for it was because of their excellence that we were victorious, not alone in that sea battle but also in the rest of the war. Indeed, it was because of them that our city earned the reputation for never being worn down by war, not even if the whole world assails us. And the reputation is a true one, for we were not subjugated by other people but by our own dissensions. We were undefeated by the others, and remain so to this day. We ourselves were the ones who defeated ourselves, we were indeed responsible for our own defeat.

243e

Socrates: "After all this, when calm had returned and we were at peace with the others, a civil war was fought,⁸ but in such a way that if strife is indeed the fate of humanity, no one would pray that his own city might suffer this disease in any other way. So readily and familiarly did the citizens of the Piraeus and the mother city consort with one another and, contrary to expectations, with the other Greeks too, so naturally did they settle the war against the forces at Eleusis, that the only explanation for all this is their genuine kinship, producing firm friendship and unity in practice, not in mere words. What's

needed then is to remember those who died at one another's hands in this war, and to reconcile them through prayers and sacrifices such as these, praying to those who now have power over them, since we too have been reconciled. For it was not through evil that we set upon one another, nor through enmity, but through misfortune. To this do we, the living, bear witness ourselves. For we, being of the same stock as those men, are forgiving towards one another for what we did and what we suffered.

244b

Socrates: “After this there was complete peace among us, the city remained quiet, we were forgiving towards the non-Greeks, because although they had suffered badly at our hands, they had nevertheless put up a decent defence. But we were angry with our fellow Greeks, remembering how, despite the good we had done them, they showed their gratitude by aligning with the non-Greeks and depriving us of the very ships that had once saved even themselves, and by dismantling our walls, the very walls we sacrificed to save their walls from falling.⁹ Our city came to the view that it would no longer defend other Greek cities when threatened with enslavement, either by Greeks or by non-Greeks, and we stood by that decision. Now, such being our thinking, the Spartans decided that since we, the protectors of freedom, had fallen, now was their opportunity to enslave the others, and they set about doing just that.

244d

Socrates: “But why prolong this? For the next events did not happen to people of old in times long past. Indeed, we ourselves know that the foremost peoples among the Greeks – the Boeotians, Argives and Corinthians – being terror-struck, came to need our city, and miraculously, so too did the King, who was so worried that he turned for salvation to no other city than our city, which he had been so eager to destroy. What's more, if anyone were to level a justifiable accusation against this city,

they could rightly accuse it only of being excessively compassionate and of favouring the weak. And, indeed, it was unable to hold out and stand by its decision not to assist any of those Greeks who had wronged it, if any of them were being enslaved. Rather, it relented, came to their aid, and by assisting them it freed the Greeks from slavery so that they were free until such time as they enslaved one another once more. But it dared not render assistance to the King for fear of bringing shame upon the victory trophies raised at Marathon, Salamis and Plateia. Rather, by allowing only exiles and volunteers to provide assistance, it undoubtedly saved him. Having refortified its walls and rebuilt its navy, it took on the struggle since it was necessary to do so, and fought for the Parians against the Spartans.

245b

Socrates: “But the King was afraid of our city because he had seen the Spartans give up on naval warfare against us. So, because he wanted to withdraw, he demanded, if he was to fight alongside us and the other allies, that we surrender the mainland Greeks whom the Spartans had previously given over to him. He assumed we would be unwilling to grant his request, thus giving him an excuse to withdraw from the alliance. In the case of the others he was mistaken, for they were willing to hand them over to him, and so the Corinthians, Argives, Boeotians, and the other allies swore a covenant to hand over the mainland Greeks if the King would give them money. But we alone dared not hand them over or swear the oath. This shows the nobility of our city and how free, resolute and sound it is, with a natural hatred of the non-Greeks because we are purely Greek, devoid of non-Greek admixture. Indeed, there dwell among us none of the offspring of Pelops, nor of Cadmus or Aegyptus, nor of Danaus, nor of the various other peoples who are non-Greeks by nature but Greeks by convention. But we live as actual Greeks, not half-non-Greeks, and so our city is imbued

with a pure hatred of this alien nature. Nevertheless, we stood alone once more because of our reluctance to perform a disgraceful and unholy deed by handing Greeks over to non-Greeks. Now, despite finding ourselves in the same predicament as led to our subjugation previously, we settled the conflict, with God's help, on better terms than we did before. For we concluded the war retaining our walls, our ships, and our own colonies, so glad too were our enemies to be quit of the conflict. Yet we lost good men in that war, as they dealt with the difficult terrain at Corinth and with treachery at Lechaenum. Good too were the men who freed the King and drove the Spartans from our waters. I am reminding you of them and it is fitting that you too should praise and glorify such men as these.

246a

Socrates: “These, indeed, were the achievements of those men who now lie here, and of the others who died for this city. Many noble deeds have been described, and many more deeds, even more noble than these, remain. Indeed, many days and nights would prove insufficient for anyone who set about recounting all of them. So what is needed is to remember these men, and every one of us should exhort their descendants, as if on the battlefield, never to withdraw from the struggle by yielding to cowardice. And so, O sons of good men, I myself am calling upon you now and hereafter, and wherever I encounter you I shall remind and exhort you to set your hearts upon being the very best of men. At the moment it is only right that I tell you what your fathers, when they were about to face danger, directed us to proclaim to those who are always left behind, in case anything was to happen to them. I will tell you what I heard from the men themselves, and also, based upon what they said then, the sort of things they might like to say to you now if they were able to do so. But you must imagine that you are hearing whatever I proclaim directly from the men themselves. What they said was this: ^{246d} ““Sons, the present situation itself makes

it plain that you were born of good fathers. We who had the opportunity to live without honour, choose rather to die an honourable death before we would draw criticism down upon yourselves and your successors, and bring shame upon our own fathers and our entire ancestry. Indeed, we believe that life is not worth living for anyone who brings shame upon his own, and that such a person is a friend neither of the gods nor of humanity, neither during his life on earth nor beneath the earth in death. So you should remember our words, and if you practise anything else, practise it along with excellence, knowing that in the absence of this all possessions and activities are shameful and base. For neither does wealth bring distinction to someone who has acquired it with cowardice, for such a person is wealthy because of something else and not because of himself, nor does beauty and strength of body appear fitting when these dwell within a base coward; they are not fitting, they make their possessor conspicuous, and they highlight his cowardice. And any knowledge that is sundered from justice and from excellence in general proves to be mere chicanery and not wisdom.

246e

Socrates: “For all these reasons you should strive in every way, first and last, by all means, to be possessed of the utmost zeal, particularly to exceed ourselves and our predecessors in glory. But mark my words, if you fall short and we triumph over you in excellence, our victory will be a source of shame, but if we lose out to you, our defeat will bring happiness. And we would best be defeated and you would triumph if you were prepared not to trade upon the reputation of your ancestors, nor to waste it, realising that for a man who thinks he amounts to something, there is nothing more disgraceful than to secure honour for himself, not in his own right, but through the reputation of his ancestors. For honours belonging to ancestors are a noble and exalted treasure to the descendants. But to use up a treasury of

wealth and honours, and bequeath none to your children because of a deficiency of wealth and reputation of your own, is base and unmanly. And if you practise these precepts, you will join us as friends meeting friends whenever fate and destiny carry you here. But if you heed them not and play the coward, no one here will receive you graciously. So let these words be spoken to our sons.

247c

Socrates: “Those of us who have fathers and mothers still living should encourage them to bear the misfortune, should it befall them, as easily as possible, and we should not join in their lamentations, for they will need no additional cause for sorrow. The present misfortune will indeed be enough to provide that. We should rather, with soothing and healing words, remind them that in matters of the greatest importance, their prayers have already been heard by the gods. For they did not pray for their sons to become immortal, but for them to become good and renowned, and they have already succeeded in these great achievements. For a mortal man, everything in his own life does not easily turn out according to plan. And if they bear the misfortunes courageously, they shall be regarded, in truth, as fathers of brave sons, who are just as brave themselves. But if they yield to unmanliness, they shall create the suspicion either that they are not our fathers, or that the people who praise us have been deceived. Neither option is acceptable. They should, rather, praise us most of all with their deeds, thus proving themselves, plainly and truly, to be the fathers of men who are indeed men. For the old saying ‘nothing in excess’ seems to be a good one and well worth quoting. That man is best equipped for life who relies upon himself for everything, or almost everything; that leads to happiness, and does not depend upon other people being compelled, as a consequence, to fare either well or badly in his own affairs as others’ misfortunes fluctuate. This is the sound-minded man, the courageous man, the wise

man. Such a man, as wealth and children come and go, will best abide by this maxim, and will, because of his self-reliance, be seen neither rejoicing nor grieving to excess.

248b

Socrates: ““These are the sort of people we ask our own kinfolk to be, such is our wish and our declaration, and we are now presenting ourselves as such, devoid of tribulation or trepidation, even if we should meet with death in the present struggle. So we implore our fathers and mothers to live out their lives with this same attitude, knowing that they will not really please us by singing dirges and lamenting over us. Rather, if the dead have any awareness of the living, they would greatly displease us by behaving in this way, by debasing themselves and bearing their sorrows so heavily. But by bearing them lightly and in due measure, they would greatly delight us. For our lives will, by then, have come to an end in the most noble death that humans can meet with, so it is more important to glorify these than to lament them. But by caring for our wives and children, and nurturing them, thus turning their attention to this world, they might best forget their misfortune and live a life that is better, more upright, and more pleasing to ourselves. That is a sufficient message to relay from us to our kindred, and we could exhort the city to look after our fathers and sons for us, educating the one systematically, while supporting the others in old age as they deserve. But we already know that the city will care adequately for these people, even without our exhortation.’

248e

Socrates: “These are the words, O children and parents of the fallen, which they directed us to relay and which I am doing my eager best to relay. And I myself, on their behalf, ask their children to imitate these people and ask their parents to be optimistic about themselves because we, both individually and collectively, shall support you in your old age and care for you

whenever any of us encounters any of you. And in the case of the city, you know, I presume, the care it exercises, and that it does so by instituting laws concerning the children and forebears of those who have died in war, and that, more than for any other citizens, the very highest authority is commanded to guard against any injustice being done to the fathers or mothers of such people. The city assists in raising their children, being eager that their status as orphans is concealed as much as possible. While they are yet children, it installs itself in the role of father, and once they have come to manhood it sends them forth on their own worldly duties arrayed in battle armour, showing them reminders of their fathers' pursuits, giving them the instruments of their paternal excellence, and at the same time, for the sake of the omen, reminding them to begin the journey back to the ancestral hearth, there to rule with power, adorned in full armour.¹⁰ The city never fails to honour these fallen men. Every year it performs the traditional rites publicly for all, the very ones that are conducted by each citizen in private. And what's more, it has instituted athletic and equestrian competitions, and contests in music of all sorts. Indeed, it stands, in general, in the position of son and heir to the departed, acting as a father of their sons and as a guardian of their parents, exercising every care for all of them always. Ponder all this and bear the misfortune more gently, for you will in this way be most pleasing to the living and the dead and will most easily serve others and yourselves. Now that you and all the others have publicly lamented the departed according to custom, you should go on your way."

249c

Socrates: There you have it, Menexenus, the speech of Aspasia of Miletus.

Menexenus: By Zeus, Socrates, Aspasia is remarkable according to you, if, being a woman, she is able to compose a speech of this

sort.

249d

Socrates: Well, if you don't believe me, come along with me and hear her speaking.

Menexenus: Socrates, I have come across Aspasia many times and I know the sort of woman she is.

Socrates: Well then, don't you admire her and aren't you grateful to her now for the speech?

Menexenus: Yes, Socrates, I am very grateful for this speech, to her or to the person, whoever it was, who relayed it to you. And for many reasons, I am grateful to the present speaker.

249e

Socrates: Very well, but please don't denounce me to her so that I may, on another occasion, relay to you lots of beautiful political speeches of hers.

Menexenus: Rest assured I shan't denounce you. Just relay the speeches.

Socrates: Yes, you will have your speeches.

NOTES

1. Lamprus was an accomplished lyre player. Antiphon of Rhamnous was the earliest of the ten Attic Orators, and is regarded as the founder of political rhetoric.
2. This refers to the dispute between Athena and Poseidon over the sovereignty of Athens. The question at issue was whether the olive tree provided by Athena or the salt-water spring that Poseidon produced on the Acropolis was more valuable.
3. Eumolpus, leading the Eleusinians, was defeated by the Athenians under the legendary King Erechtheus at Eleusis. According to legend, when the Amazons laid siege to Athens they were repelled by Theseus, who, after leading the Athenians to Thebes, secured the return of the Argive dead following the battle of the Seven Against Thebes. The Thebans were referred to as Cadmeans due to the story of the city's founding by Cadmus. Eurystheus, who ruled a number of cities in Argos, pursued the sons of Heracles, who had retreated to Athens. When Eurystheus attempted to capture them, he was defeated by the Athenians.
4. These battles took place during the second Persian invasion of Greece under Xerxes.
5. The 'extensive war' referred to here is the first part of the Peloponnesian War.
6. The 'third war' referred to here is the second part of the Peloponnesian War.
7. Following the naval battle at Arginusae, the generals were severely criticised for failing to rescue the wounded and retrieve the bodies of the dead from the sea. Plato, *Apology* 32b ff.
8. This civil war was an attempt to topple the oligarchy of the Thirty Tyrants, which had gained power at the end of the Peloponnesian War, and restore the Athenian democracy. The civil war ended with the defeat of the Thirty at Eleusis.
9. This refers to the Persian invasion led by Xerxes when the Athenians abandoned their city, taking to the sea and eventually defeating the invading forces at the battle of Salamis.
10. There was a tradition that during the festival to Dionysus, the sons of soldiers who had died in battle were presented to the public dressed in full armour in a ceremony that marked the transfer of property from father to son.

Meno

MENΩN

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

MENO from Thessaly

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

UNNAMED SERVANT from Meno's household

ANYTUS a prosecutor of Socrates

scene: unspecified public place

70a

Meno: Well, Socrates, can you tell me if excellence can be taught? Or is it incapable of being taught but attained instead through practice? Or is it incapable of either being attained through practice or learned, and does it come to people rather by nature or by some other means?

70b

Socrates: Meno,¹ previously the Thessalians were famous among the Greeks, and much admired for their horsemanship and their wealth, but nowadays I think they are also admired for their wisdom, especially the people of Larissa, the fellow citizens of your companion Aristippus.² In your case, Gorgias³ is responsible for this, for when he arrived in their city he captured the foremost of the Aleudae – among whom were your lover, Aristippus, and other leading Thessalians – since they were lovers of his wisdom. What is more, he got you into the habit of answering fearlessly and magnificently when anyone asks you anything, after the manner of those who know, by putting himself forward to be questioned by any Greeks who wish, on any topic they wish, and answering all comers.

70c

Socrates: In this part of the world, Meno, my friend, the situation is the exact opposite. It is as if a dearth of wisdom has set in, and it looks as if wisdom has departed from these regions to yours. And so, if you intend to question anyone hereabouts in that manner, there is no one who will not laugh at you and say,

“Stranger, you probably think that I am some blessed person who knows whether excellence can be taught or knows how it arises. Yet, so far am I from knowing whether excellence can be taught or not, that as it happens, I do not even know what exactly excellence itself is at all.”

71b

Socrates: That is the situation I am in myself, Meno, just as badly off as my fellow citizens in this matter, and I blame myself for knowing absolutely nothing about excellence. And when I do not know what something is, how could I know what sort of thing it is? Or do you think that anyone who is totally ignorant as to who Meno is, could know if he is handsome or wealthy or well-born or the exact opposite of these? Does this seem possible to you?

71c

Meno: Not to me. But, Socrates, is this what we are to tell our people back home, that in truth, you do not even know what excellence is?

Socrates: Not only that, my friend, but also that I have never yet come across anyone else who, in my opinion, knows either.

Meno: What? Did you not meet Gorgias when he was down here?

Socrates: I did.

Meno: Well, did you not think that he knew?

71d

Socrates: Meno, my memory is not very good, so at the moment I am unable to say how he seemed to me at the time. But perhaps he did know, and perhaps you know what the man said, so remind me of how he explained this. Or speak for yourself if you prefer, for I presume that you think what he thinks.

Meno: I do indeed.

Socrates: Then we should let the man alone since he is not here anyway. So, what about you, by the gods, Meno, what do you say excellence is? Speak and do not begrudge me in case by sheer good fortune I have been deceived, and it may turn out that yourself and Gorgias are indeed men of knowledge, despite my statement that I have never yet encountered anyone who does know.

71e

Meno: Well, it's not difficult to say, Socrates. Firstly, if you like, the excellence of a man is easy, being competent in relation to civic affairs, doing well by his friends and badly by his enemies, while being careful that he himself does not suffer such harm. Or take the excellence of a woman, that is not difficult to describe either; she should manage the household nicely, look after its contents and be attentive to her husband. The excellence of a child is different again, whether male or female. Then there is the excellence of an old man, or if you prefer, the excellence of a free man, or even the excellence of a slave. And there is a whole host of other excellences, so it is not a challenge to say what excellence is since there is an excellence for every particular activity and time of life, and for any work we engage in. And I believe, Socrates, the same goes for badness.

72a

Socrates: What a piece of good fortune, Meno! In my search for a single excellence I have discovered a swarm of them courtesy of you. Anyway, Meno, based upon this image of a swarm, if I were to ask you about the bee and what precisely its essence is, and you said that there are lots of bees of many varieties, how would you respond if I were to ask you, "So, are you saying that they are many and variegated, and that they differ from one another, in being bees? Or do they not differ in this but in some other respect, such as their beauty or size or something else of that sort?" Tell me how you would reply if you were questioned in that way.

72b

Meno: That's it, one does not differ from the other in that they are bees.

Socrates: Now, what if I were to go on and ask, "Well, Meno, tell me just what it is by which they do not differ but are all the same. What do you say this is?" You would, I presume, be able to tell me.

Meno: I would.

72c

Socrates: Similarly, in the case of the excellences, even if they are numerous and variegated, all of them possess a single form that is the same and which makes them all excellences. And when one is asked to show what excellence actually is, it would presumably be right to answer the question by looking to that form. Or do you not understand what I am saying?

Meno: Well, I think I understand, although I do not yet grasp what you are asking me as well as I'd like to.

72d

Socrates: Do you think this only applies to excellence, Meno, that there is one excellence that belongs to man, another that belongs to woman and so on? Or does it also apply to health and to size and to strength in like manner? Do you think the health of a man is one thing, while that of a woman is another? Or is the form the same in every instance where health is present, be it in a man or in anything whatsoever?

72e

Meno: I think that the health of a man and of a woman is the same anyway.

Socrates: What about size and strength? If a woman is strong, will she be strong on account of the same form and the same strength? And by "the same", I mean that strength does not differ in being strength, whether it occurs in a man or a woman.

Or do you think that it differs?

Meno: I do not.

73a

Socrates: But will excellence differ in being excellence, whether it occurs in a child or in an older person, in a man or in a woman?

Meno: To me, Socrates, this example somehow seems different from those other examples.

Socrates: What about this? Didn't you say that excellence consists for a man in the good management of a city, and for a woman in the good management of a household?

Meno: I did.

Socrates: Now, is it possible to manage a city or household or anything whatsoever, properly, without managing it sound-mindedly and justly?

Meno: Of course not.

73b

Socrates: And if they manage them sound-mindedly and justly, won't they manage them with justice and sound-mindedness?

Meno: They must.

Socrates: So, if they are going to be good, what a man or a woman both need is the same – justice and sound-mindedness.

Meno: Apparently.

Socrates: What about a child or an old person? Surely they could never become good whilst being unrestrained and unjust?

Meno: Of course not.

Socrates: What if they are sound-minded and just?

73c

Meno: Yes, then it is possible.

Socrates: So, all people are good in the same manner, since they all become good by attaining the same qualities.

Meno: So it seems.

Socrates: And obviously they would not be good in the same manner if they did not possess the same excellence.

Meno: Of course not.

Socrates: Well, given that the excellence of every person is the same, try to recount and recollect what Gorgias says that it is, since you do share his view.

73d

Meno: If you are really looking for one formulation applicable in all cases, it is the ability to rule over people.

Socrates: Yes, that is what I am looking for, but in that case, does the same excellence belong to a child and also to a slave, Meno? Can he rule over his master? And do you think someone who exercises such rule would still be a slave?

Meno: No, I don't really think so, Socrates.

Socrates: No, it is not likely, best of men. Indeed, consider the following question too. You refer to the ability to rule, shouldn't we add the words "justly and not unjustly" to this formulation?

Meno: I think so anyway, Socrates, since justice is an excellence.

73e

Socrates: Is it excellence, Meno, or is it an excellence?

Meno: What do you mean?

Socrates: This applies to anything at all. Take roundness if you like. I would say that is a shape, and not simply that it is shape, and I would refer to it in this way because there are other shapes too.

74a

Meno: And you're right to say so, since I too am saying that justice is not the only excellence. There are others.

Socrates: What are they? Tell me. I would be able to mention other shapes to you if you were to tell me to do so. Now list some other excellences for me.

Meno: Well, I think courage is an excellence, so too is sound-mindedness, wisdom and magnanimity, and there are a whole host of others.

74b

Socrates: We are in the same predicament once more, Meno. We have found numerous excellences whilst looking for one, but there is a difference this time. We are unable to find the one that runs through all of them.

Meno: Indeed, Socrates, I am not yet able, as I was in the other instances, to find what you are looking for and come up with one excellence that applies to them all.

Socrates: That is to be expected, but I am eager that we focus on this if I am able. Now you understand, I presume, that this is how matters stand in every case. If someone were to go on and ask you about what I just mentioned, "What is shape, Meno?", and you were to reply "roundness", and he were to ask you what I asked, "Is roundness shape, or is it a shape?", you would of course say that it is a shape.

Meno: Certainly.

Socrates: Isn't that because there are other shapes too?

Meno: Yes.

Socrates: And could you say what sort they are if he went on to ask you that?

Meno: I could.

74c

Socrates: And if he also asked you in the same way about colour and what it is, and when you replied “white”, the questioner then interjected, “Is white colour, or a colour?”, would you say that it is a colour because there happen to be other colours too?

Meno: I would.

Socrates: And if he told you to mention other colours, could you mention others that, as it happens, are no less colours than white is?

Meno: Yes.

74d

Socrates: Now, if, like me, he continued the argument and said, “We continually arrive at multiplicity. Do not describe it to me in this way. Rather, since you refer to these multiplicities by a single name, and you assert that every one of them is a shape – even those that are most opposite to one another – what precisely is it that prevails in round no less than in straight, which you call shape, and by which you agree that round is a shape no less than straight?” Isn’t that what you say?

Meno: I do.

Socrates: Well then, whenever you speak of them in this way, are you then asserting that round is no more round than straight, and that straight is no more straight than round?

Meno: Certainly not, Socrates.

Socrates: Yet you assert that round is no more a shape than straight is, nor is one shape more so than any other.

Meno: That’s true.

74e

Socrates: Then, what precisely is it that bears the name ‘shape’? Try to say. Now, if you were to reply to someone who questioned you in this way about shape or about colour, “Well,

good fellow, I do not understand what you want and I do not know what you mean”, he might well be surprised and say, “Do you not understand that I am looking for some one thing that is the same and applies to all these instances?” Could you not even respond in these cases, Meno, if someone were to ask, “You refer to round, straight and so on, as shapes. What is that same something that applies to them all?” Try to say what it is so that you may get some practice related to our question concerning excellence.

75b

Meno: No, Socrates, you tell me instead.

Socrates: You want me to do you a favour?

Meno: Very much so.

Socrates: And will you also be willing to tell me about excellence?

Meno: I will.

Socrates: Then we should make the effort. It is worth it.

Meno: Yes, very much so.

Socrates: Come on then, we should try to tell you what shape is. Let us see if you would accept that it is as follows. Let shape for us be that alone, among things that are, that always follows colour. Is that satisfactory for you or are you somehow looking for something different? Indeed, even if you were to describe excellence in this way I would be content.

75c

Meno: But that account is silly, Socrates.

Socrates: What do you mean?

Meno: Well, according to your account, shape, I presume, is what always follows colour. So be it. But what if someone were to say that he did not know colour, and is now just as puzzled

about that as he was about shape? What response do you think you would have given him?

75d

Socrates: The truth. And if the questioner was one of the wise, argumentative and combative types, I would say to him, “I have said what I have said, and if I am not speaking correctly it is your job to take up my argument and refute it.” However, if we were friends as you and I are now, and we wished to engage in a dialogue with one another, I would need to respond somewhat more gently and more dialectically. And the more dialectical approach is probably not only to give truthful answers, but also to proceed via whatever the person being questioned admits that he knows. So I shall endeavour to talk with you in this way too.

75e

Socrates: Now, tell me, is there something that you refer to as an end? By this I mean a sort of limit or boundary. I am saying that these are all the same. Perhaps Prodicus⁴ would take exception to this, but you, for your part, would presumably refer to something as having been “limited” or “ended.” That is the sort of thing I mean. It is nothing complicated.

Meno: Well, I do use those terms and I think I understand what you mean.

76a

Socrates: What about this? Is there anything you refer to as flat, and anything else you call solid, in the case of geometrical constructions for example?

Meno: Yes, I use these terms.

Socrates: Well, from these examples you should now understand what I mean by shape. For I am saying of every shape that this is what limits a solid. Or I might say, in short, that shape is the limit of a solid.

Meno: And what do you say colour is, Socrates?

76b

Socrates: You are quite overbearing, Meno, demanding that an old man answer hard questions when you yourself are unwilling to recollect what Gorgias said and tell me what exactly he said excellence was.

Meno: I will answer you once you have answered me, Socrates.

Socrates: From the way you converse, Meno, anyone would realise, even if they were blindfolded, that you are handsome and still have admirers.

Meno: Why so?

76c

Socrates: Because all you do when you are speaking is issue commands, just as dainty young men do, since they can exercise tyrannical power as long as they are in the bloom of youth. And you have probably recognised by now that I am at a disadvantage with handsome folk, so I will oblige you and answer your question.

Meno: Yes, certainly, do me that favour.

Socrates: Would you like me to respond, based upon the approach of Gorgias, in a way you are most likely to follow?

Meno: I would like that, of course.

76d

Socrates: Don't you both agree with Empedocles⁵ that there are certain emanations from things that are?

Meno: Emphatically.

Socrates: And are there passages into which and through which these emanations pass?

Meno: Entirely so.

Socrates: And do some emanations fit into some passages, while others are smaller or larger than the passages?

Meno: This is the case.

Socrates: Now, isn't there also something that you call sight?

Meno: Yes.

Socrates: Well, from all this, "mark thou my words",⁶ as Pindar said. For colour is an emanation from shapes which, being commensurate with sight, is perceptible.

76e

Meno: Socrates, I think your answer has been expressed excellently.

Socrates: Indeed, it was probably stated in a manner that was familiar to you, and at the same time I am sure you realise that from this answer you would also be able to say what sound is, smell too, and numerous other phenomena of this kind.

Meno: Very much so.

Socrates: In fact, Meno, the answer was dramatic, so it was more pleasing to you than the one concerning shape.

Meno: It was.

77a

Socrates: But it is not a better answer. No, son of Alexidemus, I am persuaded that the other one is better. I believe you will think so too, provided you are not compelled to leave prior to the mysteries, as you were saying yesterday, but stay about and be initiated.

Meno: Well Socrates, I would stay if you would give me lots of answers like this.

77b

Socrates: In that case I shall not be found wanting in my eagerness to deliver answers of this kind, for both our sakes,

although I may not be up to the task of delivering a lot of them. So come on, you should also try to fulfil your promise to me and explain what excellence is as a whole, and stop turning the one into many, as witty folk say every time someone breaks something. Instead you should tell me what excellence is, leaving it whole and sound in the process, now that you have these examples from me.

Meno: Well, it seems to me, Socrates, that excellence is what the poet says it is, “to delight in beauties and to have power”. This I say is excellence, to desire beautiful things and be able to acquire them.

77c

Socrates: Are you saying that someone who desires beautiful things is desirous of what is good?

Meno: Definitely.

Socrates: So, is it the case that there are some people who desire what is bad while others desire what is good? Don't you think, best of men, that everyone desires what is good?

Meno: I do not.

77d

Socrates: Then some desire what is bad?

Meno: Yes.

Socrates: Are you saying they believe that what is bad is good, or do they recognise that it is bad and desire it nevertheless?

Meno: I think they do both.

Socrates: So, Meno, do you actually think that someone who recognises that what is bad is bad, desires it nevertheless?

Meno: Definitely.

Socrates: What do you mean by ‘desires’? Does he desire that it be his?

Meno: That it be his, yes. What else could it mean?

Socrates: Does he presume that what is bad benefits the person who gets it, or does he recognise that it harms whoever has it?

Meno: There are some people who presume that what is bad benefits them, while others recognise that it harms them.

Socrates: And do you think that those who presume that what is bad benefits them, recognise that what is bad is bad?

Meno: No, I don't really think so.

77e

Socrates: Then it is obvious that these people who are unaware that it is bad, do not desire what is bad, rather they desire what they presume to be good, but is actually bad. So those who are unaware of this and presume that it is good, obviously have a desire for what is good. Isn't this so?

Meno: They probably do.

Socrates: What about this? Those people who, according to you, desire what is bad whilst believing that what is bad harms the person who gets it, don't they recognise that it will harm them?

78a

Meno: They must.

Socrates: But don't they presume that those who are harmed are wretched to the extent that they incur harm?

Meno: They must presume this too.

Socrates: And don't they presume that wretched people are in a sorry plight?

Meno: I think so.

Socrates: Is there anyone who wishes to be wretched and in a sorry plight?

Meno: I think not, Socrates.

Socrates: Well, Meno, since no one wants to be like this, no one wants what is bad. For to be wretched is to desire what is bad and obtain it, what else?

78b

Meno: It looks as though you are speaking the truth, Socrates, and that no one wants what is bad.

Socrates: Didn't you say just now that excellence is to wish for what is good and to have the power to acquire it?

Meno: I said that, indeed.

Socrates: Doesn't the wish that you mention belong to everyone, and in that respect anyway, no one is better than anyone else?

Meno: So it appears.

Socrates: It is obvious then that if one person is indeed better than another, he must be better on the basis of the power you mentioned.

Meno: Very much so.

78c

Socrates: Then according to your account, this, it seems, is excellence, the power of acquiring what is good.

Meno: Yes, Socrates, I think that the situation is exactly as you now understand it.

Socrates: Then let us see if this statement of yours is true, for you may actually have a point. Are you saying that excellence is the ability to acquire what is good?

Meno: I am.

Socrates: And do you refer to the likes of health and wealth as good?

Meno: And the acquisition of gold and silver, and of honour and high office in the city.

Socrates: Are you saying that anything else is good besides the likes of these?

Meno: No, but I am saying that everything of this sort is good.

78d

Socrates: So be it. Then according to Meno, the ancestral friend of the Great King,⁷ the acquisition of gold and silver is excellence. And would you add that this acquisition of wealth should be done in a just and holy manner, Meno, or does it make no difference to you if someone acquires it unjustly? Do you call it excellence all the same?

Meno: Of course not, Socrates.

Socrates: Then it is badness.

Meno: Entirely so.

Socrates: So, it seems that justice or sound-mindedness or holiness or some other part of excellence must accompany this acquisition of wealth, or else it will not be excellence even though it provides what is good.

78e

Meno: Indeed, how could there be excellence if these are absent?

Socrates: Yet, not to acquire gold and silver whenever it would be unjust to do so, either for yourself or for someone else, that non-acquisition would also be excellence, wouldn't it?

Meno: So it appears.

Socrates: So, the acquisition of such goods would no more constitute excellence than their non-acquisition. It seems, rather, that whatever is accompanied by justice will be excellence, and whatever is devoid of anything of this sort will

be badness.

Meno: I think that the situation must be as you describe it.

Socrates: Didn't we say a little earlier that each of these, justice, sound-mindedness and everything of that sort, is a part of excellence?

Meno: Yes.

79a

Socrates: In that case, Meno, are you playing games with me?

Meno: In what way, Socrates?

Socrates: Because earlier on I asked you not to break up excellence, or cut it into pieces, and I gave you examples of how you should respond. Yet you have paid no attention to this and you are now telling me that excellence is the ability to acquire what is good, and to do so with justice. But don't you say that justice is a part of excellence?

Meno: I do.

79b

Socrates: Then it follows from what you are agreeing to, that to enact whatever you enact along with a part of excellence, is excellence, for you accept that justice is a part of excellence and so is each of the others. Well then, why am I saying this? Because although I asked you to state what excellence is as a whole, you are far removed from saying what it is. Instead you are saying that any action is excellence as long as it is enacted along with a part of excellence, as if you had told me what excellence as a whole is, and I already recognised it, even if you also break it up into parts.

79c

Socrates: So, in my view, dear Meno, you need to face the same question again from the beginning. If every action accompanied by a part of excellence, is excellence, what then is excellence?

For that is what someone means when he says that every action accompanied by justice is excellence. Or do you think that it is unnecessary for you to face the same question once more? Do you believe, rather, that someone who does not know what excellence itself is, knows what a part of excellence is?

Meno: No, I don't think so.

79d

Socrates: Indeed, if you also remember, when I answered you earlier about shape, we rejected the sort of answer that tries to respond in terms of what is still being investigated and is not yet agreed upon.

Meno: And we were right to reject it, Socrates.

79e

Socrates: Well, best of men, do not presume that by giving an answer in terms of the parts of excellence, you will explain it to anyone when you are still investigating what it is as a whole. Nor will you explain anything else by describing it in this way. Rather, it will be necessary to face the same question once more; this excellence that you keep referring to, what is it? Or do you think I am talking nonsense?

Meno: I think that what you are saying is right.

Socrates: Then answer once more, from the beginning, what do you and your associate say that excellence is?

80a

Meno: Being perplexed yourself and making others perplexed, that is all you do, Socrates. I heard that even before I met you. And now, as I see it, you are enchanting and bewitching me, almost casting a spell on me, so that I have become utterly perplexed. And if I may be permitted a jest, I think you are extremely like the flat torpedo fish in your appearance and in other respects too. For it always numbs anyone who approaches or touches it, and I think you have just done something like that

to me, since I am truly numbed in my soul and in my mouth, and I do not have any answer to give you. Yet, on countless occasions I have delivered a whole range of speeches about excellence to lots of people, and they were really good, or so I thought anyway. But now I am not even able to say what it is at all. And I think you are well advised neither to travel abroad nor be away from home, for if you were to do this sort of thing as a stranger in another city, you would probably be locked up as a sorcerer.

80b

Socrates: You are a mischief-maker, Meno, and you almost deceived me.

Meno: What point are you making, Socrates?

80c

Socrates: I realise why you presented a likeness of me.

Meno: Why do you think I did it?

Socrates: So that I would present a likeness of you in return. There is one thing I know about all you fair fellows. You delight in playing with likenesses, it benefits you. For the likenesses of the fair are also fair, but I shall not present a likeness of you in return. Now, if the torpedo fish being numb itself also makes others numb, then I am like it, but otherwise I am not. For I do not make other people perplexed while being free from perplexity myself. No, I make other people perplexed while I am even more perplexed than anyone. And at the moment, on the question of what excellence is, I do not know, while you, perhaps, knew before you got in touch with me, but now you are like a man who does not know. But I want to look at this along with you and enquire into what exactly it is.

80d

Meno: And in what way will you enquire into something when you do not know what it is at all? Yes, what sort of thing that

you do not know will you put forward as an object of enquiry? And even if, at best, you do encounter it, how will you know that this is the thing that you did not know?

80e

Socrates: I understand the point you wish to make, Meno. Do you see that you are introducing a captious argument, according to which it is not possible for a person to enquire either into what he knows or into what he does not know? For he would not enquire into what he knows, because he knows that already, and someone like this has no need for enquiry. Neither would he enquire into what he does not know, for he does not even know what he is to enquire into.

81a

Meno: Don't you think this argument is well formulated, Socrates?

Socrates: I do not.

Meno: Can you say why?

Socrates: I can, for I have heard about matters divine from wise men and women.

Meno: What did they propose?

Socrates: Something true and beautiful, in my view anyway.

Meno: What was it and who were the people who said it?

81b

Socrates: Those who said it were priests and priestesses who cared about being able to give an explanation of their practices. Pindar expresses it too, and so do numerous other poets who are divine. What they say is as follows. Decide for yourself whether they are speaking the truth, for they say that the soul of man is immortal, and at one time it comes to an end and they call this "death", and at another time it comes to birth once more, but it is never destroyed. For these reasons then, we

should live our lives in the utmost holiness. For, “From whomsoever Persephone accepts a penalty for an ancient affliction, / Their souls she sends once more to the sun above, in the ninth year. / From these arise illustrious kings, and men, mighty in strength, supreme in wisdom, / And ever after they are called sacred heroes by humanity.”⁸

81c

Socrates: Now, since the soul is immortal and has come to birth many times, and has beheld everything there is, both here and in Hades, there is nothing she has not learned. So it is no wonder that she is able to recollect what she knew previously about excellence or about other things. Indeed, since all of nature is akin and the soul has learned all things, there is nothing to prevent someone who has only recalled one – a process that people call learning – from discovering all the others, provided he is courageous and does not tire of the enquiry, for enquiring and learning are wholly recollection. So, we should not be persuaded by this captious argument, for it will only make us idle, and it is pleasant only to the ears of feeble folk, while this one will make us active and inquisitive. Placing my trust in its truth, I want to enquire along with you into what excellence is.

81e

Meno: Yes, Socrates, but what do you mean by this statement that we do not learn and what we call learning is recollection? Can you teach me that this is the case?

Socrates: Meno, I said but a moment ago that you are a mischief-maker, and now, so that I might immediately be shown up as contradicting myself, you are asking if I am able to teach you when I am saying that there is no teaching, only recollection.

82a

Meno: Not at all, by Zeus, Socrates, that was not my intention, I said that out of habit. But if you are somehow able to prove that what you are saying holds true, please do so.

Socrates: Well, that is not easy. Nevertheless, I am willing to make the effort for your sake. So please summon for me one of these many servants of yours, whichever one you please, so that I may demonstrate this to you in his case.

82b

Meno: Certainly. You, come here!

Socrates: Is he Greek and does he speak Greek?

Meno: Yes, very much so, he was born in the house.

Socrates: Now, pay attention as to whether he seems to you to be recollecting or learning from me.

Meno: I will pay attention.

Socrates: So tell me, boy, do you recognise that a square figure is like this?

Servant: I do.

Socrates: Then a square is a figure having all of these four sides equal?

Servant: Certainly.

82c

Socrates: Doesn't it also have these lines through the middle, equal?°

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: Couldn't a figure like this be larger or smaller?

Servant: Certainly.

Socrates: Now, if this side was two feet and this was two feet, how many feet would the whole figure be? Look at it this way: if

it was two feet this way and only one foot this way, wouldn't the figure be once two feet?

82d

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: But since it is also two feet this way, wouldn't it be twice two feet?

Servant: It would.

Socrates: So, is the whole twice two feet?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: How much is twice two feet? Work it out and tell me.

Servant: Four, Socrates.

Socrates: Now, would there be another figure, double this one, but like it, having all its sides equal just as this one does?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: So, how many feet will it be?

Servant: Eight.

82e

Socrates: Come on then, try to tell me what length each side of that figure will be. Since it is two feet in this case, what length is the side of the double of this?

Servant: Obviously, Socrates, it is double.

Socrates: Meno, do you see that I am teaching this boy nothing? All I do is ask questions. And now the fellow thinks he knows the sort of line from which the eight-foot figure will arise. Is that how it seems to you?

Meno: It is.

Socrates: And does he know?

Meno: Of course not.

Socrates: Does he think the eight foot figure comes from the double line?

Meno: Yes.

Socrates: Now, watch him recollecting, in due order, in the way that one should recollect.

83a

Socrates: Tell me, boy, are you saying that the double figure arises from the double line? I am referring to a figure like this one, not long on one side and short on the other. No, let it be equal on every side, just like this one but double this one, eight feet. Now, see if this still seems to you to come from the double side.

Servant: To me, yes.

Socrates: Doesn't the side become double if we add another line of the same length, here.

Servant: Certainly.

83b

Socrates: And you say that we will get an eight-foot figure from this, once four sides of this length have been constructed?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: Then, let us draw four equal lines from this line. Is this the figure which according to you will be eight feet?

Servant: Certainly.

Socrates: In this new figure, aren't there four squares, each equal in size to the four-foot square?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: So what size has it become? Isn't it four times this size?

Servant: It must be.

Socrates: Now, is a square that is four times the size, a double?

Servant: Not at all, by Zeus.

Socrates: How many times is it multiplied?

Servant: Fourfold.

Socrates: Then, boy, the quadruple figure, and not the double figure, arises from the double side.

Servant: What you say is true.

83c

Socrates: Four times four is sixteen, isn't it?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: But what size line gives an eight-foot figure? Don't we get a quadruple space from this one?

Servant: I agree.

Socrates: And we get this quarter-sized square here, from this line here that is half as long?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: So be it. And isn't the eight-foot figure double this one, and half that one?¹⁰

Servant: Yes.

83d

Socrates: Then, it will be produced from a line that is longer than this line, but from one that is shorter than that line. Isn't this so?

Servant: I think so.

Socrates: Well said. Yes, you should answer based upon what you think. And tell me, wasn't this line two feet and that one four feet?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: Now, the line belonging to the eight-foot figure should be longer than this two-foot line, and shorter than the four-foot line.

Servant: It should.

Socrates: Now, try to state what length you claim it is.

Servant: Three feet?

83e

Socrates: Well, if it is to be three feet, shouldn't we add on a half of this line, and will it then be three feet? Yes, this is two and that is one. And on this side, in like manner, this is two and that is one, and the figure that you are referring to arises.

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: Now, if this side is three and that side is three, doesn't the entire figure become thrice three feet?

Servant: So it appears.

Socrates: And how much is thrice three feet?

Servant: Nine.

Socrates: And how many feet should the double figure be?

Servant: Eight.

Socrates: So, the eight-foot figure does not arise from the three-foot line either.

Servant: Indeed not.

84a

Socrates: From what sort of line then? Try to tell us exactly and if you do not want to give a number, point out the kind of line.

Servant: No, by Zeus, Socrates, I just do not know.

Socrates: Well, Meno, do you recognise where he is at this stage in the process of recollection? At first he did not know the

length of the side of the eight-foot figure, and even now he does not yet know. But he thought that he knew then, and he answered boldly as if he knew, and did not think that he was at a loss. But he is now at a stage where he thinks he is at a loss, since he neither knows nor even thinks that he knows.

84b

Meno: What you say is true.

Socrates: Isn't he now better off in relation to the topic he did not know?

Meno: I agree with this too.

Socrates: Now, having made him perplexed and numbed him, as does a torpedo fish, have we done him any harm?

Meno: Not in my opinion, anyway.

84c

Socrates: Indeed, it is quite likely that we have made some contribution towards finding out how matters stand, for now that he does not know he will be quite glad to search. But earlier he would have presumed readily that it is acceptable to declare repeatedly, in front of large audiences, that the double figure must have the double side.

Meno: So it seems.

Socrates: Earlier on, do you think he would have undertaken to enquire into and learn this topic, a topic which he thought he knew but did not know, before he was cast into a state of perplexity through which he realised that he did not know but yearned to know?

Meno: No, I do not think so, Socrates.

Socrates: So, has he benefited from being numbed?

Meno: I think so.

84d

Socrates: Then observe what he will discover from this perplexity by enquiring along with me, while I do no more than ask questions without teaching him. And be on the lookout in case you find me, somehow, teaching him and expounding to him rather than asking for his opinions on this.

Socrates: So tell me, boy, isn't this our four-foot figure? Do you understand?

Servant: I do.

Socrates: And may we add another figure equal to this one?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: And is this third figure equal to both of these?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: And may we fill in this space that is left in the corner?¹¹

Servant: Of course.

84e

Socrates: Now, there are these four equal figures, aren't there?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: Well then, how many times larger is the entire figure than this original figure?

Servant: Four times as large.

Socrates: But we wanted one that was twice as large, or do you not remember?

Servant: I certainly do.

Socrates: Now, doesn't this line from one corner to another cut each of these figures in two?¹²

Servant: Yes.

85a

Socrates: Then there are these four equal lines enclosing this figure here?¹³

Servant: There are.

Socrates: Now look, what size is this figure?

Servant: I do not understand.

Socrates: There are these four figures. Hasn't each internal line cut off half of each figure? Isn't this so?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: Now, how many of that size are in this?¹⁴

Servant: Four.

Socrates: How many are in that one?¹⁵

Servant: Two.

Socrates: And what is four in relation to two?

Servant: Double.

Socrates: Then how many feet is this figure?¹⁶

Servant: Eight feet.

Socrates: From what line does it arise?

Servant: From this one.¹⁷

85b

Socrates: From the one that runs from corner to corner of the four-foot figure?

Servant: Yes.

Socrates: The experts call this the diagonal. So, if 'the diagonal' is its name, then according to you, Meno's boy, the double figure would arise from the diagonal.

Servant: Yes, certainly, Socrates.

85c

Socrates: How does this seem to you, Meno? Did he respond with any opinion that was not his own?

Meno: No, they were his own.

Socrates: And yet, as we agreed a little earlier, he did not know.

Meno: That's true.

Socrates: Yet he had these opinions within him, didn't he?

Meno: Yes.

Socrates: So the person who does not know about something has true opinions within him concerning what he does not know?

Meno: So it appears.

85d

Socrates: And now these opinions have just been stirred up again within him, just like a dream. But if someone will put these same questions to him repeatedly, in varying forms, you know that he will finally come to know about these issues with as much precision as anyone.

Meno: So it seems.

Socrates: Therefore, if someone asks him questions without teaching him, he will come to know by recovering the knowledge himself, from himself.

Meno: Yes.

Socrates: But recovering knowledge himself, from himself, is recollection, isn't it?

Meno: Very much so.

Socrates: Now, isn't it the case that the fellow either acquired the knowledge he now possesses at some stage, or else he always possessed it?

Meno: Yes.

85e

Socrates: Well, if he always possessed it then he was always knowledgeable. Then again, if he acquired it at some stage it could not be during the present life that he acquired it. Or has someone taught him geometry? Indeed, he will do the same thing when it comes to any aspect of geometry or any of the other subjects. So, is there anyone who has taught him all this? You really should know, especially since he was born and reared in your own house.

Meno: Well, I know that no one has ever taught him.

Socrates: But he does possess these opinions, doesn't he?

Meno: Apparently he must, Socrates.

86a

Socrates: Yet, if he did not acquire them in his present life, is it not evident at this stage that he possessed and had learnt them at some other time?

Meno: So it appears.

Socrates: Then this was the time when he was not a human being?

Meno: Yes.

Socrates: Now, if both at the time when he was and at the time when he was not a human being, there were true opinions within him which become knowledge once awakened by questioning, does his soul then possess understanding throughout all time? For it is obvious that throughout all time he either was or was not a human being.

Meno: So it appears.

86b

Socrates: Then, if the truth about things that are is always in our soul, the soul would be immortal. And so, whatever you do not know at present is something you don't remember, and you should try bravely to enquire into it and recollect it.

Meno: Socrates, I'm not sure how, but I think you have a point.

Socrates: Yes, Meno, that is how I seem to myself too. Now, I would not affirm every aspect of this argument with total confidence, yet we would be better, more manly, and less idle, through believing that we should enquire into what we do not know, rather than believing that it is not within our power to find out or even to enquire into what we do not know. That is a proposition I would maintain insistently, as best I could, in word and in deed.

86c

Meno: Here again, Socrates, I think you have a point.

Socrates: Well, since we are of one mind that we should enquire into whatever we do not know, would you like to undertake a joint enquiry into what precisely excellence is?

Meno: Yes, certainly, and yet, Socrates, it would please me most to consider my initial question, and hear whether we should undertake this enquiry on the basis that excellence comes to people by being taught, or by nature, or comes in some manner yet to be specified.

86d

Socrates: Well, Meno, if I had control, not only of myself but also of you, we would not have considered whether excellence is teachable or not teachable until we had first enquired into what it is. However, since you do not even attempt to control yourself, so that you might actually be free, but you attempt to control me, and you do control me, I shall go along with you. What else can I do? So, it seems we must consider the sort of thing this is, when we do not yet know what it is. Now, please

relax your control over me just a little and agree to consider whether it is teachable, or how it comes to people, on the basis of a hypothesis. And by “on the basis of a hypothesis”, I am referring to just what geometers frequently consider if someone asks them about a figure; for instance, if it is possible to inscribe this triangular figure in this particular circle. One of them might reply, “I do not yet know if this figure is of this sort, yet I have a hypothesis of a kind that is applicable to this matter as follows. If this is the sort of figure that, when applied to the straight line provided by the circle, falls short by a figure like the one that has just been applied, then I think one consequence follows. But a different consequence follows if it is not possible for this to happen. So, by using this hypothesis, I am willing to tell you the solution to the problem of whether the inscription of this figure in the circle is impossible or not.”

87a

Socrates: So, we too can treat of excellence in this way, since we do not know either what it is or the sort of thing it is, by using a hypothesis to consider whether it is teachable or not teachable. We may discuss it as follows. Which of the things associated with the soul must excellence be like if it is to be teachable or not teachable? Firstly, if it is like or unlike knowledge, is it teachable or not, or as we put it a moment ago, recollectable? But it should make no difference which of the names we use. Is it teachable? Is it not obvious to everyone that people are taught knowledge and nothing else?

87b

Meno: So it seems to me anyway.

Socrates: Yes, and if excellence is a form of knowledge, it would obviously be teachable.

Meno: It would of course.

Socrates: So, we settled that issue quickly enough; if excellence is like this, it is teachable, and if it is not like this, it is not.

Meno: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Then, it seems the next thing we must consider is whether excellence is knowledge, or something different from knowledge.

Meno: Yes, this in my view is the next question we should consider.

87c

Socrates: What about this? Do we agree that excellence is something good, and does this hypothesis that excellence is good, stand according to us?

Meno: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Then, if anything else is also good, apart from knowledge, excellence might, perhaps, not be a form of knowledge. However, if nothing is good that knowledge does not encompass, our suspicion that it is a form of knowledge would be correct.

Meno: This is the case.

Socrates: What is more, we are good on account of excellence?

Meno: Yes.

87d

Socrates: And if good, then beneficent, for everything good is beneficial, is it not?

Meno: It is.

Socrates: Then excellence too is beneficial?

Meno: From what has been agreed, it must be.

Socrates: Then let us consider the kinds of things that benefit us, taking each in turn. There is health, strength, beauty and,

indeed, wealth. We say that these and the like of these are beneficial, don't we?

88a

Meno: Yes.

Socrates: But we also say that these same things sometimes do harm, or do you deny that this is the case?

Meno: No, this is the case.

Socrates: Then consider this. What is it that benefits us whenever it guides us in relation to each of these, and what is it that harms us whenever it guides us? Isn't it the case that whenever their correct usage guides us, that benefits us, and whenever it does not we are harmed?

Meno: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Well then, let us also consider this in relation to the soul. Do you say that there is sound-mindedness, justice, courage, ease of learning, retentiveness and magnanimity, and everything of that sort?

88b

Meno: I do.

Socrates: Then consider any of these that you think are not knowledge but are different from knowledge. Don't they sometimes harm us and sometimes benefit us? Take courage, for instance. If courage is not understanding, but a sort of boldness, then when a man is bold in the absence of reason, he is harmed, and when reason is present, he is benefited, is he not?

Meno: He is.

Socrates: Doesn't the same go for sound-mindedness and ease of learning; whatever is learned or inculcated is beneficial when accompanied by reason, and is harmful in the absence of

reason?

88c

Meno: Very much so.

Socrates: In short then, everything the soul undertakes and endures ends in happiness when guided by understanding, and ends in its opposite when guided by folly.

Meno: So it seems.

Socrates: So, if excellence is something that is in the soul and it is, necessarily, beneficial, then it must be understanding, since all things associated with the soul are neither beneficial nor harmful just by themselves, yet they become beneficial or harmful through the presence of understanding or of folly. So, according to this argument, since excellence is beneficial, it must be a kind of understanding.

88d

Meno: I think so.

Socrates: What is more, everything else we mentioned, wealth and the like, is sometimes good and sometimes harmful. So, just as understanding, by its guidance, makes what belongs to the soul beneficial to the rest of the soul while folly renders them harmful, so also does the soul make these beneficial by using and controlling them aright, and harmful by doing so in an incorrect manner. Isn't this so?

88e

Meno: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And does the intelligent soul guide correctly while the foolish soul leads us to error?

Meno: This is so.

Socrates: Then it is possible to declare that in general, for any person, everything else depends upon the soul, while anything belonging to the soul itself depends upon understanding if it is

to be good. And by this argument what is beneficial would be understanding, but do we accept that excellence is beneficial?

89a

Meno: We certainly do.

Socrates: Then we are saying that excellence is understanding, either the sum total, or a part thereof.

Meno: Socrates, I think this has been very well expressed.

Socrates: Well, if that is how matters stand, then good people would not be good by nature.

Meno: No, I do not think so.

89b

Socrates: Indeed, if this were so, one consequence, I presume, would be the following. If the good were good by nature, presumably there would have been people who recognised for us which of the young folk were good by nature. And once they had revealed this, we would have taken these youths in hand, guarded them in the citadel, having placed our seal upon it, as more important than gold, so that no one could corrupt them and they would be useful to their cities once they had come of age.

Meno: That sounds reasonable anyway, Socrates.

89c

Socrates: Well then, since the good are not good by nature, do they become good by learning?

Meno: At this stage I think this must be so, and obviously, Socrates, based upon the hypothesis, if indeed excellence is knowledge, it is teachable.

Socrates: Perhaps, by Zeus, but were we not right in agreeing to this?

Meno: Well, it seemed right a moment ago, at any rate, when we said it.

Socrates: But it should seem right, not only a moment ago, but also now and in the future, if it is to be at all sound.

89d

Meno: What's this? What has occurred to you? Why do you have misgivings and doubts as to whether excellence is knowledge?

Socrates: I will tell you, Meno. I am not retracting as incorrect the proposition that excellence is teachable if, in fact, it is knowledge. But consider this. Do you think it is reasonable for me to doubt whether it is knowledge? Indeed, tell me this. If anything at all, not only excellence, is teachable, mustn't there also be people who teach it and people who learn it?

Meno: Yes, I think so.

89e

Socrates: And conversely too, if there were neither teachers nor students of something, would we be right to conjecture that it is not teachable?

Meno: That is the case, but do you think there are no teachers of excellence?

Socrates: Well, I have often searched to find out whether there are any teachers of excellence, but no matter what I do I am unable to find any, even though I have conducted the search in company with many people, particularly those whom I regard as most experienced in this matter. And now Anytus¹⁸ here has sat down beside us at just the right time. Let us hand a part of the enquiry over to him. It would be reasonable for us to include him since, in the first place, Anytus here is the son of a wealthy and wise father, Anthemion, who became wealthy not by chance or by being given money, in the way that Ismenias of Thebes has just recently come into possession of the wealth of

Polycrates. No, he acquired it by his own wisdom and industry. Then again, in general, he did not seem to be an arrogant citizen, or pompous, or offensive; rather, he was a well behaved, orderly man. He then gave a good upbringing and education to his son here, as most Athenians agree, since they choose him for the most significant positions of power. So it is only right to investigate whether or not there are teachers of excellence and who they are, along with a person such as this.

90b

Socrates: So, Anytus, you should investigate this along with us, along with myself and your guest, Meno, who the teachers of this subject might be? Think about it this way, if we wanted Meno here to become a good physician, to what teachers would we send him? Wouldn't it be to the physicians?

Anytus: Yes, certainly.

90c

Socrates: And what if we wanted him to become a good cobbler? Wouldn't we send him to the cobblers?

Anytus: Yes.

Socrates: And the same goes for any other examples?

Anytus: Certainly.

Socrates: Then tell me about these same examples once again, as follows. We say that we would be right in sending him to the physicians if we wanted him to become a physician. And whenever we say this, do we mean that we would be acting sensibly in sending him to those who lay claim to this skill, rather than those who do not, and to those who charge a fee on this very basis, proclaiming themselves to be teachers of anyone who wishes to come and learn? If these were our criteria we would be right to send him, wouldn't we?

Anytus: Yes.

90e

Socrates: Don't these same criteria also apply to flute-playing and to anything else? When we wish to make someone a flautist, it is highly irrational to be unwilling to send him to those who promise to teach the skill, and who charge a fee for doing so, but to trouble some other people instead, people who neither claim to be teachers nor have a single pupil of the subject which we expect the person we send to learn from them. Don't you think that would be highly illogical?

Anytus: Yes, by Zeus, I do, and quite stupid too.

91a

Socrates: Well said. Now there is an opportunity for you and me to conduct a joint deliberation in relation to this guest here, Meno. Indeed, Anytus, the fellow has been telling me for some time that he desires that wisdom and excellence by which people manage their households and cities in the right way, care for their own parents, and know how to receive strangers or send them on their way in a manner worthy of a good man. So think about this excellence and whom we would be right to send him to, if we were to send him to someone. Or is it obvious from the earlier discussion that we should send him to those who promise to act as teachers of excellence, and proclaim themselves available as such to any Greeks who wish to learn, levying a fixed charge which they have set?

Anytus: Socrates, who are these people you are referring to?

Socrates: Surely you know yourself that these are the people whom everyone calls sophists?

91c

Anytus: By Heracles, Socrates, mind what you say. May no one acquainted with me, friend or relation, citizen or stranger, ever be gripped by such madness as to frequent these people and become warped by them, for they are evidently an affliction and a corrupting influence upon their followers.

Socrates: What do you mean, Anytus? There are many people who claim that they know how to do some good, but are these men, in particular, so different from the others that they do not benefit whatever is entrusted to them, as the others do, but they do the very opposite, they actually corrupt it? And is it for these services that they openly request financial payment? I just cannot believe you, for I know one man, Protagoras,¹⁹ who accumulated more money from this wisdom than Pheidias,²⁰ whose beautiful works are plain to see, and ten other sculptors combined. Indeed what you are saying is preposterous, since those who repair old shoes and clothing could not avoid detection for thirty days if they kept returning the clothes and shoes in worse condition than they received them. No, if they behaved like that, they would quickly die of starvation. Yet Protagoras spent more than forty years corrupting those who associated with him, and sending them away in a worse condition than when he took them on, without being noticed by the whole of Greece. For I believe he was nearly seventy when he died and had spent forty years in the profession, and throughout that entire period, and even to this very day, he was always well regarded. And not just Protagoras but a whole host of others too, some born before him, some still alive today. Well then, should we say, based upon your position, that they deceive and corrupt the young people knowingly, or without even noticing it themselves? And shall we accuse these people, whom some say are the wisest of men, of being as mad as that?

92a

Anytus: No, they are very far from madness, Socrates. In fact, it is much more the case that the young people who give them money are mad, and those who let them do so, their relatives, are even more mad, and by far the maddest of all are the cities that allow them free entry, and do not drive away any stranger who even attempts to engage in anything of this kind or any citizen either.

92b

Socrates: What is this, Anytus, have any of the sophists done you an injustice? Why are you so hard on them?

Anytus: No, by Zeus, to this day I have never even dealt with one of them, nor would I allow any of my own people to do so either.

Socrates: Then you have no experience whatsoever of these men?

Anytus: Yes, and I hope it remains so.

92c

Socrates: Blessed man, how could you know whether there is anything good or bad in their subject when you have no experience of it whatsoever?

Anytus: Easily, I know who these men are, in any case, whether I have experience of them or not.

Socrates: Perhaps you are a seer, Anytus, since from what you yourself are saying, I wonder how else you could know about these people. But of course we are not looking for the people who would make Meno worse if he went to them, let them be the sophists if you like. Tell us instead, and do a good deed for your family friend too, by advising him whom in this vast city he should go to, in order to attain eminence in the excellence I described just now.

92d

Anytus: Why don't you advise him yourself?

Socrates: Well, I have already stated who, in my view, the teachers of these excellences are, but according to you I was talking nonsense, and perhaps you have a point. So you should take your turn instead and tell him to whom he should go. Mention any name you like.

92e

Anytus: But why should he be given the name of a particular person? Indeed any noble and good Athenian he comes across will make him a better person than the sophists would, provided he is willing to take their advice.

Socrates: And did these good and respectable folk become like this spontaneously? And although they have not learned from anyone else, are they able nevertheless to teach others what they themselves have not learned?

Anytus: Well, I expect that these people have learned from their predecessors who were also good and respectable. Don't you think there have been many good men in this city?

93a

Socrates: I do, Anytus, and I think that there are people here who are good at civic affairs, and there have been just as many in the past as there are now, but were they also good teachers of their own excellence? That is the question that our discussion is concerned with, not whether there are good men here or not, nor whether there were any in the past, but whether excellence is teachable. That is what we have been considering all along. In considering this, we are considering whether the good men of today and their predecessors also knew how to impart to anyone else the excellence that made them good, or whether this is incapable of being imparted by a person, or acquired from someone else. This is what Meno and I have been investigating for some time. Consider it as follows, from your own viewpoint. Wouldn't you say that Themistocles²¹ was a good man?

Anytus: I would, him most of all.

93c

Socrates: In that case, would you say that he was also a good teacher, and if anyone was ever a good teacher of his own excellence, he was one?

Anytus: Yes, I think so, if he actually wanted to be.

93d

Socrates: But do you think he wouldn't have wanted some other people to become good and respectable, especially, I presume, his own son? Or do you think he was jealous of him and deliberately withheld the excellence whereby the man himself was good? Or have you not heard that Themistocles had his son, Cleophantus, taught to be a good horseman? Well, he used to keep his balance standing upright on horseback and throw a javelin from there. And he also performed lots of other wonderful feats in which his father had him instructed and rendered wise, all of which depended upon having good teachers. Haven't you heard this from the older generation?

Anytus: I have heard this.

Socrates: So no one could have alleged that the nature of his son was bad anyway.

93e

Anytus: Probably not.

Socrates: What about this? Have you ever yet heard from anyone, young or old, that Cleophantus, the son of Themistocles, was a man good and wise in the same accomplishments as his father?

Anytus: Certainly not.

Socrates: Well then, should we presume that although he wanted his own son to be educated in these feats, he still made him no better than the next man in the very excellence that made Themistocles himself wise, if, in fact, excellence is actually teachable.

Anytus: Probably not, by Zeus.

94a

Socrates: And yet that is the kind of teacher of excellence he was, this man who, according to you, was also among the very best men of former generations. But let us consider someone else, Aristides,²² the son of Lysimachus. Wouldn't you agree that he was a good man?

Anytus: I would, entirely so.

94b

Socrates: Didn't this man also educate his own son, better than any other Athenian, in everything that depends upon teachers? But do you think he made him a better man than anyone else? Indeed you have presumably dealt with him and you can see what he is like. Or take Pericles,²³ if you like, such a magnificently wise man. Do you know that he reared two sons, Paralus and Xanthippus?

Anytus: I do.

94c

Socrates: Then you also know that he had them taught to be horsemen, as good as any in Athens, and he had them educated to be as good as anyone in music, athletics and anything else that involves a skill. But did he not want to turn them out as good men? I think he did. He wanted to, but perhaps excellence is not teachable. And in case you think that only a few Athenians – mediocre ones at that – are unable to achieve this, bear in mind that Thucydides,²⁴ for his part, reared two sons, Melesias and Stephanus, and had them well educated in general, and they were also the best wrestlers in Athens. In fact, he entrusted one son to Xanthius and the other to Eudorus, and these were reputedly the most accomplished wrestlers of that era. Don't you remember?

94d

Anytus: So I hear, anyway.

Socrates: Isn't it obvious that if excellence can be taught, this man would never have had his own children taught these subjects whose instruction costs money, and not have had them taught the very subjects that produce good men, when that instruction costs nothing? Or was Thucydides perhaps a mediocre fellow after all, who did not have so many friends among the Athenians and her allies? He also belonged to an important family, and he had great influence in the city and throughout the rest of the Greek world. So, if excellence were indeed teachable, he would have found someone to make good men of his own sons, some fellow-citizen or some stranger, if he did not have time to do it himself because of his civic concerns. In any case, friend Anytus, it seems that excellence is not teachable.

94e

Anytus: Socrates, you seem all too ready to speak ill of people, so I would like to give you some advice, if you are prepared to heed me. Be careful, because in any city it is probably easier to do a person harm rather than do them good, but this is especially so in this city. But I think you know this yourself.

95a

Socrates: Oh, Meno, I think that Anytus is angry and I am not at all surprised. For he thinks, firstly, that I am denigrating the men I mentioned, and what is more, he believes that he himself is one of them. But if the fellow ever realises what speaking ill is actually like, he will stop being angry, but he does not realise this at the moment. However, you should tell me, aren't there noble and good men among your people too?

Meno: Very much so.

95b

Socrates: Well then, are these people prepared to put themselves forward as instructors of the young, and accept that they are teachers and that excellence can be taught?

Meno: Not at all, Socrates, by Zeus, you sometimes hear them saying that it is teachable and sometimes that it is not.

Socrates: Well, should we declare that they are teachers of this subject when they do not agree on this very issue?

Meno: I don't think so, Socrates.

95c

Socrates: What about these sophists, the only ones who actually profess to do so. Do you think that they are teachers of excellence?

Meno: That is what I admire most about Gorgias, Socrates. You would never hear him promising to do this, and he laughs at anyone else if he hears them making such a promise. Rather he believes one should turn people into clever speakers.

Socrates: So do you not even think that the sophists are teachers?

Meno: I can't say, Socrates. In fact, I am in the same position as everyone else; sometimes I think they are and sometimes that they are not.

95d

Socrates: Do you know that you and the other politicians are not the only ones who sometimes think excellence is teachable and sometimes that it is not, and that the poet, Theognis,²⁵ also says the same thing?

Meno: In what poem?

Socrates: In the elegiacs where he says, "Eat and drink with men of great power. / Sit with them and please them too. / For you will learn good from the good. / But if you consort with the bad, / You will lose even the intelligence you have."²⁶ Do you notice that in these lines he speaks as though excellence is teachable?

Meno: Apparently so.

95e

Socrates: But in other lines he changes his view somewhat. “If,” says he, “intelligence could be generated, and instilled in a man,” he says, I believe, that those who had the ability to do so “would gather large rewards aplenty”, and “Never would a good father produce a bad son, once he was persuaded by the words of the wise. But you will never make the bad man good by teaching him.”²⁷ Do you recognise that he says the opposite this time, on the same issues?

Meno: Apparently so.

96b

Socrates: Well, can you think of any other subject in which those who claim to be teachers are neither recognised as teachers of other people, nor indeed as being knowledgeable themselves, but are recognised as badly off when it comes to the very subject of which they claim to be teachers; while on the other hand, those who are themselves recognised as noble and good, sometimes claim that the subject is teachable and sometimes that it is not? Would you say that people in such confusion over an issue could be teachers in the strict sense of the word?

Meno: By Zeus, I would not.

Socrates: Well, if neither the sophists nor the good and noble people themselves are teachers of the subject, is it obvious that there would be no other teachers?

Meno: Yes, I think so.

96c

Socrates: And if there are no teachers, there are no pupils either?

Meno: I think the situation is as you describe it.

Socrates: But we have agreed that a subject that has neither teachers nor pupils is not teachable?

Meno: We have agreed.

Socrates: Now, apparently, there are no teachers of excellence anywhere?

Meno: This is so.

Socrates: And if there are no teachers, there are no pupils either?

Meno: It appears that this is so.

Socrates: So excellence would not be teachable?

96d

Meno: It seems not, if, in fact, we have considered this in the correct manner. So I really wonder, Socrates, are there any good men at all, and by what process do good people become good?

Socrates: I fear, Meno, that you and I are both mediocre fellows and that you have not been competently educated by Gorgias, nor I by Prodicus. So we should turn our attention to ourselves most of all and seek out someone who will make us better in one way or another. I say this in view of the previous enquiry, where we, quite ridiculously, overlooked the fact that it is not only under the guidance of knowledge that people conduct their affairs in a correct and competent manner. And that is probably why the understanding of the precise manner in which good men arise is escaping us too.

96e

Meno: What do you mean by this, Socrates?

97a

Socrates: As follows. Good men must be beneficent, we were right to agree that this must be the case, weren't we?

Meno: Yes.

Socrates: And were we perhaps also right to agree that they will be beneficent, if they guide our affairs aright?

Meno: Yes.

97b

Socrates: But it looks as if we were not right to agree that someone who does not have understanding is unable to guide us aright.

Meno: What do you mean?

Socrates: I will tell you. If someone who knew the way to Larissa, or anywhere else you like, were to go there and act as a guide to others, wouldn't he guide them rightly and in a competent manner?

Meno: Very much so.

Socrates: But what if someone had a right opinion as to what the way is, but had never gone there, nor did he possess the knowledge, wouldn't he also guide them aright?

Meno: Very much so.

97c

Socrates: And presumably, as long as he has right opinion concerning matters of which the other man has knowledge, he will be no worse a guide than the man who understands the matter, because what he thinks is true, even though he does not have understanding.

Meno: No worse, indeed.

Socrates: So when it comes to rightness of action, true opinion is no worse a guide than understanding. And this is what we omitted just now in considering the sort of thing that excellence is. We said that understanding alone guides us in acting aright, whereas, in fact, there was also true opinion.

Meno: So it seems.

Socrates: So, right opinion is of no less benefit than knowledge.

Meno: To a certain extent, Socrates, but the person who has knowledge would always succeed, while the person with right opinion would sometimes succeed and sometimes not.

97d

Socrates: What do you mean? Wouldn't someone who always has right opinion always succeed, as long as he forms right opinions?

Meno: Apparently he must, so I wonder, Socrates, in that case, why exactly knowledge is regarded as much more valuable than right opinion, and in what respect they differ from one another?

Socrates: Do you know why you are wondering, or should I tell you?

Meno: You really should tell me.

Socrates: It is because you have not paid attention to the statues of Daedalus,²⁸ but perhaps where you come from there are none.

Meno: What are you getting at, Socrates?

Socrates: That these too, if they have not been tied down, take flight and run away, yet once they have been tied down, they stay in place.

Meno: So what?

97e

Socrates: To acquire one of this man's creations when it has been let loose is of no great value. It is just like acquiring a runaway slave: it does not stay in place. But once it has been tied down it is very valuable, for his works are extremely beautiful. Now, what have I in mind when I refer to these statues? I am thinking of true opinions. For true opinions, too,

are a worthy possession for as long as they remain with us and everything they accomplish is good, yet they are not inclined to stay in place for long; rather, they run away out of a person's soul, and so they are not very valuable until the person ties them down by working out the cause. And this, my friend Meno, as we agreed earlier, is recollection. Once they have been tied down, they become knowledge and are stable. And that is why knowledge is valued more highly than right opinion, and knowledge differs from right opinion in being tied down.

98a

Meno: Yes, by Zeus, Socrates, it seems to be something of this sort.

98b

Socrates: And yet, I too am speaking as someone who does not know, someone who is making conjectures. But I do not think I am merely conjecturing that right opinion and knowledge are different; rather, if indeed I were to claim to know anything, and there is little I would claim, this is one thing I would include among things that I know.

Meno: And rightly you say so, Socrates.

Socrates: What about this? Isn't it right to say that true opinion is no less effective than knowledge in guiding the performance of each activity?

Meno: Yes, I think that is also true, Socrates.

98c

Socrates: So, right opinion will not be at all inferior to knowledge or less beneficial to our activities, nor will a man who has right opinion be less beneficent than a man with knowledge.

Meno: Quite so.

Socrates: And, indeed, we agreed that the good man is beneficent.

Meno: Yes.

98d

Socrates: Well then, since it is not because of knowledge alone that men are good and beneficent to their cities, if they are, but also because of right opinion, and since neither of these, neither knowledge nor right opinion, belongs to people by nature...²⁹ Or do you think either of them is present by nature?

Meno: I do not.

Socrates: Well, since these are not present by nature, neither would the good be good by nature.

Meno: Of course not.

Socrates: And since they are not good by nature, we went on to consider whether excellence is teachable.

Meno: Yes.

Socrates: Didn't it seem that if excellence is understanding, it is teachable?

Meno: Very much so.

98e

Socrates: And if there were any teachers it would be teachable, and if there were none it would not be teachable?

Meno: Quite so.

Socrates: But then have we agreed that there are no teachers of excellence?

Meno: We have.

Socrates: So, have we agreed that it is not teachable, nor is it understanding?

Meno: Entirely so.

Socrates: But do we agree that it is good?

Meno: Yes.

Socrates: And that whatever guides us aright is beneficial and good?

Meno: Entirely so.

99a

Socrates: And that these two alone, true opinion and knowledge, guide us aright, and the person who possesses them guides aright. For whatever unfolds aright due to chance does not happen through human guidance. But whatever is guided aright by man is really guided by these two, true opinion and knowledge.

Meno: I think this is so.

Socrates: In that case, since excellence is not teachable, can excellence still be knowledge?

Meno: Apparently not.

99b

Socrates: So, one of the two things that are good and beneficial has been ruled out, and knowledge would not be our guide in political activity.

Meno: I think not.

99c

Socrates: So, men such as Themistocles and people like him, and those whom Anytus here mentioned earlier, do not guide their cities by means of any wisdom or by being wise. That is also why they are unable to turn others into men like themselves. It is because they are not the sort of men they are on account of knowledge.

Meno: That is probably how matters stand, Socrates.

Socrates: Well, if this does not happen by means of knowledge, then what is left is sound opinion. Through recourse to this the

statesmen regulate their cities, being no better off than soothsayers and prophets when it comes to knowledge. For these people too speak many and true things whilst divinely inspired, but they have no knowledge of what they are saying.

Meno: It looks as if this is so.

99d

Socrates: In that case, Meno, don't these men deserve to be called divine, when they successfully accomplish so much that is so important, in their deeds and in their words, without possessing reason?

Meno: Very much so.

Socrates: So we would be right to refer to the prophets and soothsayers, whom we just mentioned, as divine, and all the poets too. And we would declare that the statesmen too are no less divine and divinely inspired than these, being inspired and possessed by the god whenever they achieve success when speaking on so many important issues, knowing nothing about what they are speaking of.

Meno: Entirely so.

99e

Socrates: And the women too, doubtless, refer to good men as divine, Meno, and whenever the Spartans praise some good man, they say "this man is divine".

Meno: And they appear to be speaking correctly, Socrates, although Anytus here will perhaps be annoyed with you for saying this.

100a

Socrates: That does not concern me; we shall converse with him some other time. But now, if we have enquired and spoken properly throughout this entire discussion, excellence would not be natural, nor could it be taught; rather, it would come to those who receive it as a divine portion, without reason, unless

there were among our statesmen someone capable of turning another person into a statesman. And if there were such a person, he might almost be described among the living as Homer describes Teiresias among the dead, when he says of him “He alone, of those in Hades, is conscious. / While the others are flitting shadows.”³⁰ In the same way, here among us, such a person would also be true substance, alongside shadows, when it came to excellence.

100b

Meno: I think you have expressed that beautifully, Socrates.

100c

Socrates: Well then, Meno, based upon this reasoning, it appears to us that excellence accrues to those who receive it as a divine portion. However, we shall know this with clarity when we first set about investigating what precisely excellence is in itself, before considering the manner in which excellence accrues to people. But it is now time for me to go somewhere else, and you should also convince your friend Anytus here of the very same things you yourself have been persuaded of so that he may be more gentle. For if you do persuade him, you will do a service to the people of Athens too.

NOTES

1. Meno was a general from Thessaly, probably from Pharsalus. He also appears in Xenophon's *Anabasis*.
2. Aristippus was a member of the Aleudae, the most prominent family in Thessaly, and a lover of Meno.
3. Gorgias was a noted and influential rhetorician and sophist from Leontini in Sicily. He has an eponymous dialogue.
4. Prodicus was a sophist from Ceos who was known for his teaching on the correct use of words.
5. Empedocles was a philosopher from Acragas in Sicily. Gorgias was said to be a student of Empedocles.
6. Fragment 105, Snell.
7. This is a reference to the King of the Persian (Achaemenid) Empire.
8. Fragment 133, Snell.
9. Socrates draws a square figure in the sand, adding two lines that intersect in the centre of the figure, running from the centre of one side to the centre of the opposite side.
10. That is, the 8ft square is double the 4ft square, which is based on a line that is 2ft long, and half the 16ft square, which is based on a line that is 4ft long.
11. Socrates constructs a 16ft square out of four 4ft squares by filling the space in the corner.
12. Socrates then draws diagonal lines that bisect each of the four 4ft squares that make up the 16ft square.
13. That is, the new square, which is constructed from the four diagonal lines and inscribed within the 16ft square.
14. Again, the new square, which is constructed from the four diagonal lines and inscribed within the 16ft square.
15. That is, in one of the original 4ft squares.
16. Again, the new square, which is constructed from the four diagonal lines and inscribed within the 16ft square.
17. From the diagonal line that bisects each of the four 4ft squares.
18. Anytus was an Athenian politician and one of Socrates' accusers. *Apology* 23e.

19. Protagoras of Abdera was an influential sophist and teacher of rhetoric. He is depicted in Plato's eponymous dialogue, and positions attributed to him are considered in Plato's *Theaetetus*.
20. Pheidias was a sculptor, painter and architect. Among his many important works was the gold and ivory statue of Zeus at Olympia, one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World, and the statue of Athena at the Parthenon in Athens.
21. Themistocles was a famous Athenian politician and general. He successfully led the Athenians in repelling two invasions by the Persian (Achaemenid) Empire.
22. Aristides, nicknamed 'the Just', was an Athenian politician and general. He was a leader of the Athenian resistance against the Persian invasion.
23. Pericles was among the most famous Athenian statesmen and orators of the 5th century.
24. Not to be confused with the famous historian of the Peloponnesian War, Thucydides, son of Melesias, an Athenian politician and rival of Pericles.
25. Theognis was a lyric poet from Megara.
26. Theognis, *Elegies*, lines 33-36, Diehl.
27. Theognis, *Elegies*, lines 434-438, Diehl.
28. Daedalus was a skilled architect and craftsman. He was said to have sculpted figures so real they appeared to live and move.
29. Omitting οὐτέπικτητα at 98d1.
30. *Odyssey* x.494-495.

Minos¹

MINΩΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES *of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus*

A COMPANION *from Locri Epizephyrri, Italy*

scene: no setting

313a

Socrates: What, for us, is law?

Companion: What kind of laws are you asking about?

Socrates: What's this? Does law differ from law on the particular basis of being law? Consider what I'm actually asking you. It's as if I had asked you what gold is, and you, as you have just done, were to ask me what kind of gold I meant. I believe you would not be questioning me in the correct manner. For gold, presumably, does not differ at all from gold, nor does stone from stone, on the basis of stone being stone or on the basis of gold being gold. And so, neither does law, I presume, differ at all from law. They are, rather, all the same thing, for each of them is a law, none is more so and none is less so. So this is my specific question: what, in general, is law? If you have a ready answer, let's hear it.

313b

Companion: What else could law be, Socrates, except whatever is conventional?

313c

Socrates: And do you think that speech is whatever is spoken, or sight is whatever is seen, or that hearing is whatever is heard? Or is speech other than what is spoken, sight other than what is seen, and is hearing one thing while whatever is heard is something else? And is law, in that case, one thing, while whatever is conventional is something else? Is this so, or how does it seem to you?

Companion: To me, at the moment, they seem different.

Socrates: So law, then, is not whatever is conventional.

Companion: I don't think so.

313d

Socrates: What, then, would law be? Let's investigate this as follows. If someone asked us about what has been said just now, "Since you say that whatever is seen is seen by sight, what is this sight by which they are seen?", we would reply that it is the sense perception that reveals things through the eyes. Suppose he were to go on and ask us, "Well then, since whatever is heard is heard by hearing, what is this hearing?", we would reply that it is the sense perception by which sounds are revealed to us through the ears. Well, what if he were also to question us in this way, "Since it is by law that whatever is conventional is conventional, what is this law by which they are conventional? Is it some sense perception, or an explanation, just as whatever is learned is learned by being explained by knowledge? Or is it discovery, just as whatever is discovered is discovered in the way that, for instance, what is healthy or unhealthy is discovered by medicine, and the intentions of the gods are, according to the soothsayers, discovered by prophecy, since skill, for us, is presumably the discovery of things? Is this so?"

314c

Companion: Entirely so.

Socrates: So, which of these might we best assume law to be?

Companion: The various decisions and decrees, in my opinion at any rate. What else could anyone declare law to be? So it is most likely, to respond to your question, that law in general is a decision of a city.

Socrates: You seem to be saying that law is political opinion.

Companion: I am.

314d

Socrates: And you may perhaps be right, but we may know better, as follows. Do you say that some people are wise?

Companion: I do.

Socrates: Aren't the wise people wise by wisdom?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: And what about the just people? Aren't they just by justice?

Companion: Certainly.

Socrates: Are not the lawful people lawful by law?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: Are the lawless people lawless by lawlessness?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: Are the lawful people just?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: Are the lawless people unjust?

Companion: Unjust.

Socrates: Are not justice and law most noble?

Companion: Quite so.

Socrates: And injustice and lawlessness are most base?

Companion: Yes.

314e

Socrates: And one preserves the city and everything else, while the other destroys and overturns them?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: So, we should regard law as something noble and seek it as something good.

Companion: Of course.

Socrates: Didn't we say that law is a decision of a city?

Companion: We said so, indeed.

Socrates: Well then, are some decisions good while others are evil?

Companion: Indeed so.

Socrates: And yet, law was not evil.

Companion: Indeed not.

Socrates: In that case, it is not correct to reply so simply that law is a decision of a city.

Companion: No, I don't think so.

Socrates: So it would not be appropriate for an evil decision to be law.

Companion: No, indeed.

315a

Socrates: And yet it is quite apparent to me, for my part, that law is an opinion. But since it is not evil opinion, it is obvious by now, is it not, that it is good opinion, if law is indeed opinion?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: But what is good opinion? Is it not true opinion?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: And true opinion is discovery of what is?

Companion: It is, indeed.

Socrates: So law purports to be discovery of what is?

Companion: How then is it, Socrates, if law is discovery of what is, that we do not always have recourse to the same laws in relation to the same issues if things that are have been

discovered by us?

315b

Socrates: Law, nonetheless, purports to be the discovery of what is. So those people who apparently do not have recourse to the same laws are not always able to discover what the laws purport to discover, namely, what is. Come on, let's see whether it may become clear to us, from here on, whether we always have recourse to the same laws or use different laws at different times, and also whether we all have recourse to the same laws, or different people use different laws.

315c

Companion: Socrates, it is not difficult to recognise that the same people do not always have recourse to the same laws, and also that different people use different laws. Since, among ourselves here, at the moment, the law forbids human sacrifice; it is unholy, whereas the Carthaginians perform such sacrifices, as for them these are holy and conventional, and some of them even sacrifice their own sons to Cronus, as you may perhaps have heard. And it is not just non-Greeks who have recourse to different laws from ours, but even the people of Lycia and the descendants of Athamas perform such sacrifices, even though they are Greeks. And you know, I presume, about ourselves too, having heard about the kinds of laws we had recourse to in the past concerning the dead, laws whereby we first slaughtered sacrificial victims before the corpse was carried out, and engaged women to gather the bones into an urn. Then again, still earlier generations than these used to bury their dead in the house, but we do not follow any of these practices. And it would be possible to give lots of similar examples. Indeed, there is much scope for demonstrating that we ourselves do not always legislate on the same basis among ourselves, nor do people in general do so with one another.

315d

Socrates: I would not be at all surprised, best of men, if you were right in what you are saying and this is something I had overlooked. But as long as you state your opinions in your own way in a lengthy speech, and I do likewise, I don't think we will come to any conclusions. But if the enquiry were common to us both, we might perhaps come to agreement. So, engage with me in a common enquiry by putting questions to me if you wish, or by answering my questions if you prefer.

315e

Companion: I am willing, Socrates, to answer any questions you like.

Socrates: Come on then, are you accustomed to thinking that whatever is just is unjust, and whatever is unjust is just, or alternatively that whatever is just is just, while whatever is unjust is unjust.

Companion: I am accustomed to thinking that whatever is just is just, and whatever is unjust is unjust.

316a

Socrates: And aren't they conventionally thought of in this way by everyone, in the same way as they are thought of here?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: Among the Persians too?

Companion: Even among the Persians.

Socrates: Always, I presume?

Companion: Always.

Socrates: Are things that offer more resistance conventionally regarded as heavier here, and those that offer less resistance as lighter, or is it the other way around?

Companion: No, whatever offers more resistance is heavier, whatever offers less is lighter.

Socrates: Is this also the case in Carthage and Lycia?

Companion: Yes.

316b

Socrates: And people everywhere conventionally think of whatever is good as good and whatever is base as base, and not that what's base is good and what's good is base.

Companion: Quite so.

Socrates: So, is it not the case, generally speaking, that we ourselves, and all other people too, conventionally think that things that are, are what they are, and not what they are not?

Companion: I think so.

Socrates: So, whoever is in error about what is, is in error about what is conventional.

316c

Companion: Socrates, according to your formulation these all appear conventional, both for ourselves and anyone else. But as long as I bear in mind that we never stop changing our laws this way and that, I cannot be persuaded.

Socrates: Indeed, perhaps you are not bearing in mind that when moving the pieces on a draughts board, the pieces are the same. But look at this closely with me. Have you ever come across writings concerning the health of sick people?

Companion: I have.

Socrates: Well, do you know what skill the treatise belongs to?

Companion: I do, it belongs to the skill of medicine.

Socrates: Don't you refer to those who are knowledgeable about these matters as physicians?

Companion: I agree.

316d

Socrates: Now, do those who are knowledgeable conventionally think the same things about the same matters, or do they differ?

Companion: The same things, in my opinion.

Socrates: Is it only Greeks who conventionally think the same things as their fellow Greeks concerning issues they know about, or does this also apply to non-Greeks, both with themselves and with Greeks?

Companion: There is a strong necessity, I presume, that those who know, be they Greeks or non-Greeks, should agree in thinking the same things.

Socrates: A good answer. And isn't this always the case?

Companion: Yes, indeed, always.

Socrates: Don't the physicians commit to writing whatever views they conventionally hold in relation to health?

Companion: Yes.

316e

Socrates: So, these writings of the physicians are medical writings and are medical laws.

Companion: Yes, medical.

Socrates: So, the agricultural writings are agricultural laws?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: What about writings and conventions of horticultural work? To whom do these belong?

Companion: To the gardeners.

Socrates: So, these are our horticultural laws?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: Belonging to those who know how to take charge of gardens?

Companion: Of course.

Socrates: And it is gardeners who know this.

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: To whom do the writings and conventions about the preparation of food belong?

Companion: To the cooks.

Socrates: So, these are culinary laws?

Companion: Culinary.

Socrates: Belonging, it seems, to those who know how to take charge of food preparation?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: And it is cooks, they say, who know this?

317a

Companion: Yes, they know.

Socrates: Very well. To whom then do the writings and conventions concerning the administration of the city belong? Don't they belong to those with knowledge of taking charge of cities?

Companion: I think so.

Socrates: And who else besides the political people and the kingly people know this?

Companion: These are the people.

317b

Socrates: So, these writings are political writings which people refer to as laws. They are the writings of kings and of good men.

Companion: True.

Socrates: Now, those who are knowledgeable do not write different things at different times about the same matters, do

they?

Companion: No.

Socrates: Nor will they ever change their conventions from one to another on the same matters.

Companion: Indeed not.

Socrates: So, if we see any people anywhere doing this, should we declare that those who are doing so are knowledgeable or not knowledgeable?

Companion: Not knowledgeable.

Socrates: And wouldn't we say that whatever is correct is the convention on each subject, be it medicine, cookery or gardening?

317c

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: And we shall never declare that what is not correct is the conventional thinking?

Companion: Never.

Socrates: So, it happens to be unlawful.

Companion: Necessarily.

Socrates: Isn't it also the case in the writings dealing with what's just and what's unjust, and the general administration of the city, and how the city should be managed, that what is correct is the kingly law, and what's not correct is not this, even though it seems so to those who do not know. In fact, it is unlawful.

Companion: Yes.

317d

Socrates: So, we were right when we agreed that law is the discovery of what is.

Companion: Apparently.

Socrates: Let's also examine the following point about this matter. Who is it who knowledgeably distributes seeds on the land?

Companion: A farmer?

Socrates: Does he distribute the seeds that are appropriate for each type of land?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: So, the farmer is good at distributing these, and his laws and distributions for these purposes are correct?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: And who is good at distributing notes to melodies and distributes them appropriately, and to whom do the correct laws here belong?

317e

Companion: They belong to the flautist and the citharist.

Socrates: So, in these distributions the person who is most skilled in the laws is the most skilled flautist.

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: And who is best at distributing nutriment to people's bodies? Isn't it the person who distributes the appropriate nutriment?

Companion: Yes.

318a

Socrates: So, his distributions and his laws are best, and whoever is most skilled in the laws concerning these matters is best at making the distribution.

Companion: Indeed so.

Socrates: Who is this person?

Companion: A trainer.

Socrates: And he is the one who is best at pasturing the human herd of the body?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: And who is best at pasturing a herd of sheep? What is his name?

Companion: A shepherd.

Socrates: So, the laws of the shepherd are best for the sheep.

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: And the laws of the cowherd are best for the cows.

Companion: Yes.

318b

Socrates: And whose laws are best for the souls of humans? Aren't they the laws of the king? Do you agree?

Companion: I agree.

Socrates: You are answering well. Now, can you say who among the ancients proved to be a good lawgiver in the laws of flute-playing? Perhaps you don't recall; would you like me to remind you?

Companion: Very much so.

Socrates: Was it not said to be Marsyas and his beloved, Olympus of Phrygia?²

Companion: That's true.

318c

Socrates: And their compositions for the flute are indeed most divine, being the only ones that stir and reveal the people who are in need of the gods. And still, to this day, they remain the

only compositions that do this, because they are divine.

Companion: This is so.

Socrates: And among the ancient kings, who is said to have been a good lawgiver whose conventions still remain to this day because they are divine?

Companion: I can't think of anyone.

318d

Socrates: Don't you know which Greek peoples make use of the most ancient laws?

Companion: Are you referring to the Spartans and Lycurgus, their lawgiver?

Socrates: But these are, perhaps, not yet three hundred years old, or a little older. Do you know, rather, where the best of the conventions come from?

Companion: From Crete they say.

Socrates: So, among the Greeks, these people make use of the most ancient laws?

Companion: Yes.

Socrates: Now, among these people, do you know who the good kings were? They were the offspring of Zeus and Europa, Minos and Rhadamanthus, whose laws these were.

318e

Companion: They say, Socrates, that Rhadamanthus, at any rate, was a just man, but that Minos was wild, harsh and unjust.

Socrates: Best of men, you are reporting a story from Attic tragedy.

Companion: What? Isn't this what is said about Minos?

Socrates: Not by Homer and Hesiod at any rate. Yet these two are more credible than all those tragedians put together, from

whom you have heard what you are now saying.

319a

Companion: Well, what do they say about Minos?

Socrates: I'll tell you then, so that you don't commit an impiety as most people do. For there is nothing more impious and nothing we should be more careful to avoid than error in word and deed in relation to the gods, or secondly, in relation to divine humans. You must, rather, employ great foresight whenever you are about to criticise or praise anyone, in case you speak incorrectly. That is why we should learn to distinguish between good and evil people. For the god gets angry whenever anyone criticises someone who is like himself, or when anyone praises someone of the opposite sort, the former being a good person. Indeed, you should not think that there are sacred stones, pieces of wood, birds and serpents, but no sacred humans. A good human being is, rather, more sacred than all these, while an evil one is more wretched.

319b

Socrates: And that is why I shall now speak about Minos, as Homer and Hesiod praised him, lest you, a human being of human birth, fall into error in speaking of a hero and a son of Zeus. For Homer, telling us that Crete had a large population and ninety cities, says that "Among them is Cnossus, a great city where Minos was king in the ninth season holding converse with mighty Zeus."³ So this is Homer's praise of Minos, briefly stated, but unlike anything Homer wrote about any of the heroes. That Zeus is a sophist, and that this skill is entirely noble he makes clear in various places, and especially here. For he means to say that Minos converses with Zeus every ninth year, visiting him regularly for educational purposes, as if Zeus were a sophist. So, the fact that the privilege of being educated by Zeus is assigned to none of the heroes apart from Minos is wondrous praise indeed. And in the *Odyssey*, in the 'Book of the

Dead', he describes Minos, but not Rhadamanthus, passing judgement, holding a golden sceptre.⁴ But here he does not describe Rhadamanthus passing judgement, nor anywhere meeting with Zeus. That's why I maintain that Minos has been praised by Homer more than all the others. For being a child of Zeus, and the only one educated by Zeus, is unsurpassed praise. Indeed, this is the meaning of the verse that says "in the ninth season holding converse with mighty Zeus".

319e

Socrates: Minos is a companion of Zeus, since conversations are discourses and a conversation partner is a companion in discourse. So Minos visited the Cave of Zeus every nine years in order to learn and in order to demonstrate what he had learned from Zeus over the previous nine-year period. There are those who understand 'holding converse' as being a drinking companion or playmate of Zeus, but you may use the following as evidence that those who understand the words in this way are talking nonsense. For of all the peoples there are, Greeks and non-Greeks, there are none who refrain from drinking parties and the playfulness born of wine except the Cretans, and the Spartans too, who learned this from the Cretans. In Crete, among the various laws that Minos instituted, there is one whereby they are not to drink together to the point of drunkenness. And it is evident that whatever he thought noble, he instituted as conventions for his fellow citizens. For Minos did not, of course, behave like some ordinary fellow and think one thing while enacting something else contrary to what he thought. No, his meeting was, as I say, through discourse for the purposes of education in excellence. That's why, for his fellow citizens, he instituted these laws through which Crete is happy for all time, and Sparta too, once it began to make use of them, since they are divine.

320c

Socrates: But Rhadamanthus was a good man, for he had been educated by Minos. He had not, however, been educated in the entire skill of kingship, but in a skill subservient to kingship sufficient to preside in courts of law, and that's why he was said to be a good judge. Indeed, Minos used him as a guardian of the law in the city, and used Talos for the same purpose in the rest of Crete. For Talos went around the villages three times a year as guardian of the law, having the laws inscribed on brass tablets, hence he was called 'brazen'. And Hesiod too says something similar to this about Minos. For having mentioned his name, he says: "Who proved to be the most kingly of mortal kings, lord over most of the neighbouring peoples, holding the sceptre of Zeus by which he also exercised kingship over the cities."⁵ And by 'the sceptre of Zeus' he simply means the education he received from Zeus, by which he governed Crete.

320e

Companion: In that case, Socrates, how on earth has the report been spread abroad that he was an uneducated, harsh person?

Socrates: Because of something, best of men, that you, if you are sound-minded, will be careful about, as will anyone who is going to preserve his reputation. Never cross any of the poetical folk, for the poets have enormous influence on reputations depending on whether they eulogise or demonise their subjects. And this was the mistake Minos made in waging war on this city of ours in which there is, in general, much wisdom and a great variety of poets of every sort, and tragedians too. For tragedy is of ancient date here, beginning not as people think with Thespis, nor with Phrynichus.⁶ Rather, if you care to think about it, you will find that this is a most ancient discovery made in this very city. And tragedy is the most popular and appealing form of poetry in which we attack Minos in revenge for those tributes he compelled us to pay.⁷ So, this was the mistake Minos made, being angry with us. Hence, to answer your question, he

has come to have an increasingly bad reputation. He was good and lawful and, as we said previously, good at distributing, and the strongest indication of this is the fact that his laws are unchanging, since they belong to someone who, in relation to the management of the city, well discovered the truth of what is.

321b

Companion: The argument you have presented sounds probable to me, Socrates.

Socrates: In that case, if I am speaking the truth, do you think that the Cretan citizens of Minos and Rhadamanthus made use of the most ancient laws?

Companion: Apparently.

Socrates: So, these two proved to be the best lawgivers of the ancients, shepherding and distributing to the people, just as Homer said that a good general is a shepherd of the multitude.⁸

Companion: Very much so.

321c

Socrates: Come on then, in the name of Zeus, god of friendship, what if someone were to ask us, “What is it that the good lawgiver, who is good at distributing to the body, distributes to the body to make it better?” We would reply, rightly and briefly, that it is nutriment and exertion to develop the body itself on the one hand, and to exercise and establish it on the other.

Companion: Correct.

Socrates: What if he were then to ask us, “What precisely is it that the good lawgiver, who is good at distributing, distributes to the soul to make it better?” How might we respond if we were to avoid shame to ourselves at our age?

321d

Companion: At this stage, I can no longer say.

Socrates: Well, it is a shame then, on the soul of each of us, that it is so plainly ignorant of that within it which is good or bad for it, even though it has considered what's good and bad for the body and much else.

NOTES

1. Most scholars doubt that Plato was the author of this work.
2. Marsyas was a legendary musician who was credited with having developed the skill of playing wind instruments by picking up and playing an aulos (a kind of double oboe, which is translated here as ‘flute’) that was left behind by Athena. Olympus was credited with having introduced instrumental music to Greece from Phrygia in the East.
3. *Odyssey* xix.178-179.
4. The ‘Book of the Dead’ refers to the *Odyssey*, Book xi. For the account of Minos passing judgement with his golden sceptre see *Odyssey*, xi.568-571.
5. Hesiod, Fragment 144.
6. Thespis is variously credited with having been the first actor in a play, having introduced the principal actor and the chorus, and having been the inventor of tragedy. Phrynichus was a student of Thespis and one of the first tragedians.
7. According to legend, after defeating the Athenians, Minos demanded that a tribute of seven young men and seven young women be sent by Athens to Crete every nine years as food for the Minotaur.
8. *Iliad* i.263, *Odyssey* iv.532.

Parmenides

ΠΑΡΜΕΝΙΔΗΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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narrator: CEPHALUS of Clazomenae

persons in the dialogue:

ADIMANTUS *Athenian, son of Ariston, Plato's brother*

ZENO *of Elea, student of Parmenides*

SOCRATES *of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus*

PARMENIDES *of Elea, philosopher and teacher*

ARISTOTELES *Athenian of Thorae, son of Timocrates*

scene: outside the city walls of Athens at the house of Pythodorus, during the Great Panathenaea

126a

When we arrived in Athens from Clazomenae, our hometown, we came across Adimantus and Glaucon¹ in the Agora. Adimantus took me by the hand and said, "Greetings, Cephalus. If there is anything you want here, anything we can do for you, just ask." "In fact," said I, "that's the very reason I'm here, to ask you for something." "Tell us what you want," he said.

126b

"Your half-brother," I replied, "on your mother's side, what was his name? I have forgotten it. He was just a child when I came to Athens previously from Clazomenae, and that was a long time ago now. I think his father's name was Pyrilampes." "Indeed so," he replied. "And his name was?" "Antiphon. But why are you asking?"

126c

"These men here," said I, "are fellow citizens of mine, serious philosophers who have heard that this man, Antiphon, had numerous meetings with a certain Pythodorus, a companion of Zeno's,² and that he had heard the discussions that took place between Socrates and Zeno and Parmenides³ so often from Pythodorus that he could recite them from memory." "That's true," he replied. "Well," said I, "we want to hear an account of these discussions." "That is no problem," said he. "Indeed, as a

young man he studied these, although nowadays he takes after his grandfather of the same name and busies himself, for the most part, with horses. But if you want we can go to visit him. He left here a while ago to go home, but he lives nearby in Melite.”

127a

With that, we set off on foot and we came across Antiphon at home, giving a bit of some sort to a smith to work on. When he had finished with the smith, the brothers told him why we were there. He recognised me from my previous visit, and greeted me. When we asked him to recount the discussions, he was reluctant at first, saying that it involved a lot of work, but he eventually gave us a detailed account.

127b

Antiphon explained that, according to Pythodorus, Zeno and Parmenides had come to Athens once for the Great Panathenaea.⁴ Parmenides was by then well advanced in years, a grey-haired, sixty-five-year-old man of noble and handsome appearance. Zeno was almost forty at the time, tall and good-looking, and it was said that he had once been a favourite of Parmenides. They were staying, he said, with Pythodorus outside the walls in the Kerameikos. Socrates arrived, accompanied by a number of others who wished to hear a reading of Zeno’s writings which had been brought to Athens for the first time by these two visitors. Socrates was quite young at the time. While Zeno himself was reading to them, Parmenides happened to be outside.

127c

Pythodorus said that when he himself came in, along with Parmenides and Aristoteles, who later became one of The Thirty, very few of the arguments still remained to be read, and they listened to a small number of writings, although he himself had actually heard them before from Zeno.

127d

Having listened, Socrates asked that the first hypothesis of the first argument be read again, and once it had been read, he said,

Socrates: “What do you mean by this Zeno? If things that are, are many, they must actually be both like and unlike, but this is an impossibility since what’s unlike cannot be like, nor can what’s like be unlike. Is that what you are saying?”

Zeno: “It is,” said Zeno.

127e

Socrates: “So if it is impossible for what’s unlike to be like and for what’s like to be unlike, then isn’t it also impossible for them to be many? For if they were many, they would be subject to impossible outcomes. So isn’t this the intention of your arguments, solely to contend, contrary to everything that is said, that things that are, are not many? You think, don’t you, that each of your arguments is a proof of this very claim, and so you believe that you have provided as many proofs as written arguments to the effect that things that are, are not many? Is this what you mean, or have I misunderstood you?”

Zeno: “No,” said Zeno. “On the contrary, you have well understood the intent of the book as a whole.”

128a

Socrates: “Well Parmenides,” said Socrates, “I am discovering that Zeno here wishes to be close to you not only in general friendship, but also in his book. For he has, in a way, written the same thing as yourself, but by making some changes he tries to deceive us into believing that he is saying something different. For you say in your poems that ‘all is one’, and you provide excellent, elegant proofs of this assertion, while this man, for his part, says that it is not many,⁵ and he too provides lots of extensive proofs. So with one of you saying that it is one, and the other that it is not many, and each speaking as if you had seemingly not said the same things, while saying more or less

the same things, what you have said appears to have been spoken over the heads of the rest of us.”

128b

Zeno: “Yes, Socrates,” said Zeno, “but you have not fully appreciated the truth about the book, although like the hounds of Sparta, you hunt down the arguments and follow their trail quite well. In the first place, you are unaware of the fact that the book is not really so serious as to have been written with the intention you are describing, while concealing it from people as if that was some significant achievement. No, you are referring to something incidental, while in truth this is a support to Parmenides’ argument against those who try to make fun of it on the grounds that if it is one, many absurdities and self-contradictions follow from that proposition. This book then opposes those who speak for the many and pays them back with the same and more, intending to demonstrate that this hypothesis of theirs, that it is many, incurs even greater ridicule, if someone sufficiently presses the point, than the hypothesis that it is one. I wrote the book in this sort of combative spirit in my early years, but once it had been written, someone plagiarised it, so I was not allowed to decide whether it should see the light of day or not. So, this is the point you have missed, Socrates. You think it was written out of an older man’s ambition rather than a young man’s combative spirit. Although, as I said, your comparison is not a bad one.”

128e

Socrates: “I accept that,” said Socrates, “and I believe that the circumstances were as you say. But tell me this. Don’t you think that there is a form, just by itself, of likeness, and again another form, opposite to this, that which unlike is? And don’t you and I, and whatever else we call many, get a share of these two? Don’t those that get a share of likeness become like in the way that, and to the extent that, they get a share, while those that get a share of unlikeness become unlike, and those that get a share of

both become both? And even if all things get a share of both, although they are opposites, and by partaking of both become like as well as unlike themselves, is that a surprise?

129b

Socrates: “Indeed if someone were to show the likes themselves becoming unlike, or the unlikes becoming like, that I think would be extraordinary. But if he shows that whatever partakes of both of these is characterised in both ways, that does not seem at all unusual to me, Zeno, nor indeed if he shows that all things are one by partaking of the one, and these same things are again many by partaking of multiplicity. But if someone can prove that this itself, what one is, is many, or in turn that the many are indeed one, at this I will be surprised. And the same holds for all of the others. If someone could show the kinds and forms themselves, in themselves, being characterised by these opposite characteristics, that would be worthy of surprise. But why be surprised if someone can show that I am one and many by saying, when he wants to show that I am many, that my right side is different, my left side is different, my front is different, my back is different, and the same goes for my upper and lower parts, since I presumably partake of multiplicity?

129d

Socrates: And when he wants to show that I am one, he will say that I am one person of the seven of us here, since I also partake of the one. And so he shows that both assertions are true. So if, in the case of stones and sticks and the like, someone were to show that such objects are many and also the same one, we shall maintain that he has shown that something is one and many, not that the one is many or that the many is one, and he is not saying anything surprising, but something we would all accept. But if someone were first to distinguish as separate the forms, just by themselves, of the things I just mentioned, 129e such as likeness, unlikeness, multiplicity, the one, rest and motion and the like, and then show that these are capable of being

combined and separated among themselves, I for one, Zeno, would admire him wonderfully,” said he. “And although I believe you have dealt with these issues very thoroughly, I would, as I say, have much more admiration for someone who could demonstrate that this very same difficulty that you and Parmenides described among visible things, is involved ^{130a} in all sorts of ways in the forms themselves, in things that are grasped by reasoning.”

^{130a}

Pythodorus said that while Socrates was saying all this, he himself thought that at any moment Parmenides and Zeno might get annoyed, but on the contrary they paid close attention to him and occasionally glanced at one another and smiled as if they admired Socrates.

^{130b}

Parmenides confirmed this when Socrates stopped speaking, by saying,

Parmenides: “Socrates, you deserve to be admired for your drive towards arguments, but tell me this. Do you, as you say, distinguish as separate, certain forms by themselves, and as separate too, whatever partakes of the forms? And do you think that likeness itself is something separate from the likeness that we have, and indeed one and many and everything else you heard of just now from Zeno?”

^{130c}

Socrates: “I do, indeed,” said Socrates.

Parmenides: “And what about things of this sort,” said Parmenides, “things like the just, beautiful and good and everything of this sort? Is there a form just by itself in each case?”

Socrates: “Yes,” he said.

Parmenides: “And what about a form of human being separate from us and from all those who are like us? Is there a form itself of human being, or fire, or even water?”

Socrates: “I have often been in perplexity about these, as to whether I should speak of them just as I spoke of the others, or speak of them differently.”

Parmenides: “What about the following things, Socrates, which may seem ridiculous, for example, hair, mud and dirt, or anything else totally contemptible or commonplace? Are you perplexed as to whether or not you should say there is also a separate form of each of these which, in turn, is different from anything we handle?”

130d

Socrates: “Not at all,” said Socrates. “No, these are just what we see them to be. Surely it would be most strange to think that there is a form belonging to these. At that stage, I am troubled sometimes lest there might be something that is the same about all these. Then, whenever I end up in that predicament I take flight, afraid that I might sink into some pit of nonsense and be undone. Finally, getting back to those things which we have just said have forms, I spend my time dealing with these.”

130e

Parmenides: “You are still young, Socrates,” said Parmenides, “and philosophy has not yet taken hold of you as, in my opinion, it will in the future when you will hold none of these things in contempt. For the moment however, because of your youth, you still look to the opinions of other people. In any case, tell me this: does it seem to you, as you say, that there are certain forms of which these other things get a share and adopt their names? For example, getting a share of likeness, do they become like, getting a share of largeness do they become large, and getting a share of beauty and of justice do they become just and beautiful?”

Socrates: “Indeed so,” replied Socrates.

131a

Parmenides: “Doesn’t whatever gets a share in each case get a share either of the whole form or of a part? Or could there be some other way of getting a share besides these two?”

Socrates: “How could there be?”

Parmenides: “Do you think that the whole form, being one, is in each of the many? Or what do you think?”

Socrates: “What’s to prevent this, Parmenides?” said Socrates.

Parmenides: “So, being one and the same, it will be present simultaneously as a whole in things that are many and separate, and would thus be separate from itself.”

131b

Socrates: “No, Parmenides,” said he, “not if it is like a day, which being one and the same is in many places simultaneously, and is, nevertheless, not separate from itself. If this were the case, each of the forms could simultaneously be one and the same in all things.”

Parmenides: “Socrates, how nicely you make the one and the same be in many places simultaneously, as if you were to throw a sail over many people and maintain that one, as a whole, is over many. Don’t you think something like this is what you are saying?”

Socrates: “Perhaps.”

Parmenides: “Would the sail as a whole be on each person or just a part of this, and another part on another person?”

Socrates: “A part.”

131c

Parmenides: “So, forms themselves are divisible, Socrates, and things that partake of them would partake of a part, and would

no longer be in each as a whole, but a part of each form would be in each.”

Socrates: “Apparently so.”

Parmenides: “Well then, Socrates, do you wish to maintain that our one form is in truth divided and will still be one?”

Socrates: “Not at all.”

131d

Parmenides: “Indeed, look at it this way. If you are going to divide largeness itself, and each of the many large things is to be large by a part of largeness, smaller than largeness itself, won’t that appear unreasonable?”

Socrates: “Very much so.”

Parmenides: “What about this? Will each thing that has received a small part of the equal be equal to anything else by possessing a part that is less than the equal itself?”

Socrates: “Impossible.”

131e

Parmenides: “But some of us will have a part of the small, and the small will be greater than this part since this is a part of itself, and the small itself will in this way be larger, while whatever the subtracted part is added to will be smaller, not larger, than before.”

Socrates: “Well, that couldn’t happen,” he said.

Parmenides: “In that case, Socrates, in what way will the others get a share of your forms when they are unable to get a share either on the basis of parts or on the basis of wholes?”

Socrates: “No, by Zeus,” he responded, “I don’t think it is easy to decide such a question at all.”

Parmenides: “What about this then? Where do you stand on the following question?”

Socrates: “Which is?”

132a

Parmenides: “I presume that you think that each form is one for some such reason as this. Whenever many things seem to you to be large, perhaps there seems to be one characteristic that is the same as you survey them all. Hence you think that the large is one.”

Socrates: “That’s true.”

Parmenides: “What about the large itself and the other large things? If you survey all these in the same way with the soul, won’t some one large appear, in turn, by which all these large things appear large?”

Socrates: “So it seems.”

132b

Parmenides: “So, another form of largeness will make an appearance alongside the largeness itself that has come into being, and whatever partakes of this, and another, in turn, over all these, by which all these will be large, and each of your forms will be one no longer but unlimited in multiplicity.”

Socrates: “But Parmenides,” said Socrates, “couldn’t each of the forms be a thought of these, and it would not be appropriate for this to arise anywhere else besides in souls? For in this way, each form could be one and would no longer be affected by everything that has just been described.”

Parmenides: “Then,” Parmenides replied, “is each of the thoughts one, but a thought of nothing?”

Socrates: “No, that’s impossible,” he said.

Parmenides: “So, it is a thought of something?”

Socrates: “Yes.”

132c

Parmenides: “Of something that is or something that is not?”

Socrates: “Something that is.”

Parmenides: “Isn’t it of some one which that thought thinks is set over all of them as one characteristic?”

Socrates: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “That something, which is thought to be one, being always the same over all of them, won’t that be a form?”

Socrates: “Again, this appears necessary.”

Parmenides: “What about this, then?” asked Parmenides. “By the necessity by which you maintain that the others partake of the forms, do you think either that each is from thoughts and everything thinks, or although they are thoughts, they are devoid of thinking?”

132d

Socrates: “No, this is not reasonable either,” he said. “But Parmenides, what appears most obvious to me is that these forms stand like patterns in nature, while the others resemble these and are likenesses, and for the others this partaking of forms turns out to be nothing else but resembling them.”

132e

Parmenides: “Now,” Parmenides replied, “if something resembles the form, can that form fail to be like whatever resembles it, insofar as that has been made like the form? Or is there some way that the like is unlike its like?”

Socrates: “There is not.”

Parmenides: “And isn’t there a strong necessity that the like partakes of one and the same thing as what it is like?”

Socrates: “It is necessary.”

Parmenides: “But what do the likes partake of so as to be like? Won’t that be the form itself?”

Socrates: “Entirely so.”

133a

Parmenides: “So nothing can be like the form, nor can the form be like anything else. Otherwise, alongside the form another form will always make an appearance. And if that form is like something, yet another form will appear, and the continual generation of a new form will never cease if the form turns out to be like whatever partakes of it.”

Socrates: “Very true.”

Parmenides: “Since it is not by likeness that the others get a share of the forms, we must rather look for something else by which they get a share.”

Socrates: “So it seems.”

Parmenides: “Do you see then, Socrates,” said he, “the extent of the difficulty once someone distinguishes forms as being just by themselves?”

Socrates: “Very much so.”

133b

Parmenides: “Mark my words, you have not yet, so to speak, grasped the extent of the difficulty that arises if you propose one form for each of the things that are, in each case, by continually separating something off.”

Socrates: “How so?”

Parmenides: “Though there are various other reasons, the main one is this. If someone were to maintain that if forms are such as we say they must be, it is not in their nature even to be known, no one would be able to show someone who says so that he is wrong, unless the objector happened to be naturally gifted, and have lots of experience and a willingness to follow a very extensive and far-reaching demonstration dealing with the issue. Otherwise, the person who insists that the forms are

unknowable would remain unconvinced.”

Socrates: “Why is that Parmenides?” Socrates asked.

133c

Parmenides: “Because, Socrates, I would imagine that you and anyone else who proposes that there is, for each, some being just by itself, would agree in the first place that none of these are among us.”

Socrates: “Indeed not. How could it still be just by itself?”

Parmenides: “Well said,” Parmenides replied. “Therefore, those characteristics that are what they are in relation to one another have their being in relation to themselves, and not in relation to whatever is with us, whether someone posits likeness or whatever else he suggests we partake of and are named after in each case. While those that are with us, although they have the same names as the forms, are, in turn, what they are in relation to themselves and not in relation to the forms. And whatever things are named in this way refer to themselves and not to those forms.”

133d

Socrates: “What do you mean?” asked Socrates.

Parmenides: “For instance,” said Parmenides, “if one of us is the master or slave of someone, he is not, of course, the slave of master itself, what master is; nor is a master, master of slave itself, what slave is. Rather, as human beings, we are master or slave of a fellow human. Mastery itself, on the other hand, is what it is of slavery itself, while slavery itself, in like manner, is slavery of mastery itself.

133e

Parmenides: But the things among us do not have their power towards those, nor do those have their power towards us. Rather, as I say, these are what they are, of themselves and in relation to themselves, while things with us are, in like manner,

relative to themselves. Or do you not understand what I am saying?"

134a

Socrates: "I understand," said Socrates, "very much so."

Parmenides: "And is it also the case that knowledge itself, what knowledge is, would be knowledge of that truth itself, what truth is?"

Socrates: "Entirely so."

Parmenides: "Then again, each of the instances of knowledge, what each is, would be knowledge of particular things that are. Isn't this so?"

Socrates: "Yes."

134b

Parmenides: "The knowledge with us would be knowledge of the truth with us, and furthermore, particular knowledge with us would turn out to be knowledge of particular things that are with us?"

Socrates: "Necessarily."

Parmenides: "But the forms themselves, as you agree, we neither possess nor can they be with us."

Socrates: "No, indeed not."

Parmenides: "And presumably each of the kinds themselves is known by the form of knowledge itself?"

Socrates: "Yes."

Parmenides: "Which we do not possess."

Socrates: "We do not."

Parmenides: "So none of the forms is known by us since we do not partake of knowledge itself."

Socrates: “Apparently not.”

134c

Parmenides: “So what beauty itself is, and the good, and indeed everything we understand as being characteristics themselves, are unknown to us.”

Socrates: “Quite likely.”

Parmenides: “Then consider something even more daunting.”

Socrates: “Which is?”

Parmenides: “You would say, I presume, that if there is indeed a kind, just by itself, of knowledge, it is much more precise than the knowledge with us, and the same holds for beauty and all the others.”

Socrates: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Now, if anything else partakes of knowledge itself, wouldn’t you say that a god, more so than anyone, possesses the most precise knowledge?”

Socrates: “Necessarily.”

134d

Parmenides: “In that case, will a god possessing knowledge itself be able to know things in our realm?”

Socrates: “Why not?”

Parmenides: “Because, Socrates,” said Parmenides, “we have agreed that those forms do not have the power that they have, in relation to the things that are with us, nor do the things with us have their power in relation to those forms. The power in each case is in relation to themselves.”

Socrates: “Yes, we agreed on that.”

134e

Parmenides: “Well then, if this most precise mastery is with a god, and this most precise knowledge too, the gods’ mastery would never exercise mastery over us, nor would their knowledge know us nor anything else that is with us. Rather, just as we neither rule over them with our rule nor do we know anything of the divine with our knowledge, they in turn by the same argument, are not the masters of us nor do they have knowledge of human affairs, although they are gods.”

Socrates: “But surely if someone were to deprive a god of knowledge, the argument would be most surprising.”

135a

Parmenides: “Indeed, Socrates,” said Parmenides, “the forms inevitably possess these difficulties and many others besides these, if there are these characteristics of things that are, and someone marks off each form as something by itself. And the person who hears about them gets perplexed and contends that these forms do not exist, and even if they do it is highly necessary that they be unknowable to human nature. And in saying all this he seems to be making sense, and as we said before, it is extraordinarily difficult to persuade him otherwise. Indeed, this will require a highly gifted ^{135b} man who will have the ability to understand that there is, for each, some kind, a being just by itself, and someone even more extraordinary who will make this discovery and be capable of teaching someone else who has scrutinised all these issues thoroughly enough for himself.”

Socrates: “I agree with you, Parmenides,” said Socrates. “What you are saying is very much to my mind.”

Parmenides: “Yet on the other hand Socrates,” said Parmenides, “if someone, in the light of our present considerations and others like them, will not allow that there are forms of things that are, and won’t mark off a form for each one, he will not even have anywhere to turn his thought, since

he does not allow that a characteristic of each of the things that are is always the same. And in this way he will utterly destroy the power of dialectic. However, I think you are well aware of such an issue.”

135c

Socrates: “That’s true.”

Parmenides: “Well then, what will you do about philosophy? In what direction will you turn while these are unknown?”

Socrates: “Well at the moment I don’t think I can see an answer.”

Parmenides: “Socrates,” said he, “that is because you are trying to mark off something beautiful, just and good, and each one of the forms too soon before you have been trained. Indeed, I noticed this earlier as I listened to you in discussion here with this man Aristoteles. Now, mark my words, although the drive you bring to arguments is noble and divine, you must bestir yourself while you are still young and get more training in something that seems useless and which most people call idle talk, or else the truth will escape you.”

135d

Socrates: “What is the manner of the training, Parmenides?” he asked.

Parmenides: “The same as what you heard from Zeno,” he replied, “with the following exception. I was indeed delighted when you said that you would not allow the enquiry to be about visible things or to consider their wandering. It was rather to consider things that one apprehends mainly by reason and might think to be forms.”

Socrates: “That,” said he, “is because by the other approach I think it is all too easy to show things that are, being characterised as both like and unlike or as anything else at all.”

135e

Parmenides: “And you are right to say so,” he said. “But it is also necessary to do something else in addition. It is not enough to consider the consequences that follow from hypothesising that each is, but you must also hypothesise that this same thing is not, if you wish to be better trained.”

Socrates: “How do you mean?” he asked.

136a

Parmenides: “Take for instance, if you like,” said he, “this hypothesis that Zeno proposed, ‘if many are’.⁶ What are the consequences for the many themselves in relation to themselves and in relation to the one, and for the one in relation to itself and in relation to the many. And furthermore, if many are not, you need to consider what the consequences will be both for the one and for the many in relation to themselves and one another. And again, if you hypothesise ‘if likeness is’ or ‘if likeness is not’, what will follow from either hypothesis, both for the things hypothesised themselves, and for the others, both in relation to themselves and one another. And the same argument applies when dealing ^{136b} with unlikeness, with movement, with rest, with generation, with destruction, with being itself, and with non-being. And in a word, whatever you may ever hypothesise as being, or as not being, or as characterised by any other characteristic whatsoever, you should consider the consequences both in relation to itself and in relation to each of the others, whichever you choose, and in relation to a number of them, and in relation to them all together in the same way, and the others too for their part, both in relation to themselves and in relation to anything else you may ever choose, ^{136c} whether you hypothesise it as being or as not being, if you are to be perfectly trained to have a supreme vision of the truth.”

Socrates: “Parmenides,” said he, “you are describing an enormous undertaking which I do not really understand. Why

don't you go through the process yourself for me by hypothesising something so that I may better understand this."

136d

Parmenides: "For a man of my age, Socrates," he replied, "you are assigning a huge task."

Socrates: "Well, Zeno," said Socrates, "why don't you go through a hypothesis for us?"

136e

And Pythodorus said that Zeno laughed and replied,

Zeno: "We should ask Parmenides himself, for he is describing something that is far from commonplace. Don't you see the extent of the task you are assigning him? Now, if there were more of us here it wouldn't be right to ask him, for it is not appropriate to speak of such matters in front of lots of people, especially at his age. Indeed, most people are unaware that without this detailed and extensive exploration it is impossible to encounter the truth and acquire reason. And so, Parmenides, I join Socrates in his request so that I too may hear you out to the very end after all these years."

137a

When Zeno had said all this, Antiphon told us that Pythodorus said that he himself, along with Aristoteles and the others, implored Parmenides to demonstrate what he was speaking of, nothing else would do. So Parmenides said,

Parmenides: "I must comply although I feel as if I am in the same predicament as the horse in Ibycus' poem,⁷ the aged competitor who is about to compete in a chariot race and, because of past experience, trembles at the prospect. The poet comparing himself to this animal said that he himself, an old man, was being compelled against his will to embark upon amorous pursuits. And as I think back, I too, it seems, am fearful as to how at my age I am to swim across such a vast sea of

arguments. Nevertheless, I should oblige you since indeed, as Zeno says, we are by ourselves. So, where shall we begin and what shall we hypothesise first? Or ^{137b} since it seems I am to play this laborious game, would you like me to begin with myself and my own hypothesis by hypothesising about the one itself, and what the consequences must be if it is one or not one?"⁸

Zeno: "Yes, certainly," said Zeno.

Parmenides: "Who," asked Parmenides, "will respond to me? Perhaps the youngest? Yes, he will make least trouble and will be most inclined to answer based upon what he thinks, and at the same time his answering would give me a rest."

^{137c}

Aristoteles: "I'm ready for that, Parmenides," said Aristoteles, "since you are referring to me when you refer to the youngest. So ask your questions and I will answer you."

Parmenides: "Very well," said he. "If one is,⁹ the one would not be many, would it?"

Aristoteles: "No, how could it be?"

Parmenides: "So, of this there is no part, neither could it be a whole."

Aristoteles: "Why is that?"

Parmenides: "The part is presumably part of a whole."

Aristoteles: "Yes."

Parmenides: "And what about the whole? Wouldn't that from which no part is missing be a whole?"

Aristoteles: "Certainly."

Parmenides: "So in both cases the one would consist of parts both by constituting a whole and by having parts."

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

137d

Parmenides: “So in both cases the one would thus be many, but not one.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

Parmenides: “But it should not be many, but just one.”

Aristoteles: “It should.”

Parmenides: “So, if the one is to be one, it will neither be a whole nor will it have parts.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “Now, if it does not have a part it would not have a beginning, an end, or a middle, for these sorts of things would already be parts of it.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

Parmenides: “And indeed, a beginning and an end are a limit of each thing.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

137e

Parmenides: “So the one is limitless if it has neither a beginning nor an end.”

Aristoteles: “Limitless.”

Parmenides: “So it is without shape, for it partakes neither of round nor straight.”

Aristoteles: “How so?”

Parmenides: “Well, whatever has its extremities everywhere the same distance from the middle is presumably round.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And indeed, something is straight if the middle intercepts both extremities.”

Aristoteles: “Quite so.”

Parmenides: “Then the one would have parts and would be many if it were to partake of straight or round shape.”

Aristoteles: “Yes certainly.”

Parmenides: “So it is neither straight nor round since, in fact, it does not have parts.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

138a

Parmenides: “And indeed, being like this, it would be nowhere at all, for it would neither be in another nor in itself.”

Aristoteles: “How so?”

Parmenides: “Being in another, it would presumably be encompassed in a circle by whatever it was contained in, and would touch this in many places with many parts. However, since it is one, and devoid of parts, and does not partake of circularity, it is impossible for it to touch in many places in a circle.”

Aristoteles: “Impossible.”

138b

Parmenides: “Then again, being in itself it would, by itself, encompass nothing other than itself, if it were actually in itself, for it is impossible for anything to be in something and not be encompassed by it.”

Aristoteles: “Impossible, indeed.”

Parmenides: “In that case, whatever encompasses would be one thing, and whatever is encompassed would be another, for the same thing will not simultaneously, as a whole, be both active and passive, and thus the one would no longer be one but

two.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “So the one is not anywhere, neither in itself nor in another.”

Aristoteles: “It is not.”

138c

Parmenides: “This being the case, consider whether it can be at rest or in motion.”

Aristoteles: “Why could it not be?”

Parmenides: “Because being in motion it would either be transported or altered, for these are the only motions.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “But it is impossible, presumably, for the one still to be one while being altered from itself.”

Aristoteles: “Impossible.”

Parmenides: “So it does not move by alteration at least.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently not.”

Parmenides: “In that case, is it transported?”

Aristoteles: “Perhaps.”

Parmenides: “And yet, if the one were transported it would either be borne around in a circle in the same place, or change location from one place to another.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

138d

Parmenides: “Now, being borne around in a circle, it must stand upon a centre and have all that is borne around that centre as other parts of itself. But in what way is that to which neither centre nor parts belong, ever to be borne in a circle

upon a centre?”

Aristoteles: “There is no way.”

Parmenides: “Well then, does it come to be in different places at different times by changing place? Is that how it moves?”

Aristoteles: “If it actually does move.”

Parmenides: “Didn’t it appear impossible for it to be somewhere, in something?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “So isn’t it even more impossible for it to come to be somewhere in something?”

Aristoteles: “I don’t understand how.”

Parmenides: “If it is coming to be in something, isn’t it necessary that it not yet be in that something while it is still coming to be in that? Nor can it still be entirely outside that if indeed it is already coming to be in it.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

138e

Parmenides: “Now, if this is to happen to anything, it could only happen to something that has parts, for some of it could already be in that thing while, at the same time, some is outside. But that which has no parts will presumably not be able, in any way, to be neither wholly inside something nor wholly outside, at the same time.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

Parmenides: “But isn’t it even more impossible for that which has no parts and is not a whole, to come to be in something, somewhere, since it cannot come to be in something else, either part by part, or as a whole?”

Aristoteles: “Apparently.”

139a

Parmenides: “So it does not change place by going somewhere or coming to be in something, nor is it borne about in the same place, nor is it altered.”

Aristoteles: “It seems not.”

Parmenides: “So, on the basis of every movement, the one is unmoving.”

Aristoteles: “Unmoving.”

Parmenides: “And yet we also say that it cannot be in something.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, so we say.”

Parmenides: “So it is never in the same.”

Aristoteles: “Why?”

Parmenides: “Because it would then be in that, in the same that it is in.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “But it was unable to be either in itself or in another.”

Aristoteles: “It was indeed.”

Parmenides: “So the one is never in the same.”

Aristoteles: “It seems not.”

139b

Parmenides: “But that which is never in the same is neither still nor at rest.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed, it cannot be.”

Parmenides: “So the one, it seems, is neither at rest nor in motion.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, so it appears anyway.”

139c

Parmenides: “Then it will neither be the same as another or itself, nor would it be different from itself or from another.”

Aristoteles: “Why is that?”

Parmenides: “Being somehow different from itself, it would be different from one and would not be one.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

Parmenides: “And indeed, being the same as another it would be that and not itself, and so in this way it would not be just what it is, namely one, it would rather be different from one.

Aristoteles: “Indeed.”

Parmenides: “So it will not be the same as another, or different from itself.”

Aristoteles: “It will not.”

Parmenides: “Yes, and it will not be different from another as long as it is one, for it does not belong to the one to be different from anything. It belongs rather to different alone, and to nothing else to be different from another.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

Parmenides: “So it will not be different by being one. Or do you think it could?”

Aristoteles: “Of course not.”

139d

Parmenides: “And yet, if it will not be different by this, it will not be so by itself, and if not by itself it will not, itself, be different, and being in no way different itself it will be different from nothing.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

Parmenides: “Nor indeed will it be the same as itself.”

Aristoteles: “Why not?”

Parmenides: “The nature of the one is not of course the nature of the same.”

Aristoteles: “Why is that?”

Parmenides: “Because once something has become the same as something, it does not become one.”

Aristoteles: “What happens?”

Parmenides: “Having become the same as many, it must become many and not one.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

Parmenides: “But if the one and the same did not differ at all, whenever something became the same it would always come to be one, and whenever it became one it would always come to be the same.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

139e

Parmenides: “So, if the one is to be the same as itself, it will not be one with itself, and accordingly, although it is one, it will not be one. But this is indeed impossible. So it is impossible for the one either to be different from another or the same as itself.”

Aristoteles: “Impossible.”

Parmenides: “In this way then, the one would neither be different from, nor the same as, itself or another.”

Aristoteles: “It would not.”

Parmenides: “Nor indeed will it be like or unlike anything, either itself or another.”

Aristoteles: “Why is that?”

Parmenides: “Because whatever is characterised as the same is presumably like.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “But the same appeared to be separate in nature from the one.”

Aristoteles: “So it appeared.”

Parmenides: “And yet if the one were characterised as anything besides being one, it would be characterised as being more than one, and that is impossible.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

140a

Parmenides: “So the one is not characterised as being like either another or itself.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently not.”

Parmenides: “So it cannot be like either another or itself.”

Aristoteles: “It seems not.”

Parmenides: “Nor indeed is the one characterised as being different, for in this way too it would be characterised as being more than one.”

Aristoteles: “More indeed.”

140b

Parmenides: “And yet whatever is characterised as different from itself or another would be unlike itself or another, since whatever is characterised as the same is like.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

Parmenides: “Then the one, it seems, is not characterised as being in any way different from, or in any way unlike, either itself or another.”

Aristoteles: “It is not.”

Parmenides: “So the one would neither be like, nor unlike, either itself or another.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently not.”

Parmenides: “And indeed, being like this, it will be neither equal nor unequal to itself or another.”

Aristoteles: “Why is that?”

Parmenides: “Being equal it will be of the same measures as that to which it is equal.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

140c

Parmenides: “And presumably, if it is greater or lesser it will have more measures than whatever is lesser than it, and fewer measures than whatever is greater, in cases where it is commensurable.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “But in cases where it is not commensurable, its measures will be either smaller or greater.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “Now, isn’t it impossible for that which does not partake of the same, to be of the same measures or the same anything else at all?”

Aristoteles: “Impossible.”

Parmenides: “In that case, since it is not of the same measures, it would not be equal either to itself or to another.”

Aristoteles: “Well, it certainly appears not.”

140d

Parmenides: “Furthermore, being of more measures, or of fewer, it would have as many parts as it has measures, and thus the one would again be one no longer but as many as its measures.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

Parmenides: “But if it was of one measure it would become equal to that measure, but this appeared impossible; it was impossible for the one to be equal to anything.”

Aristoteles: “It appeared so indeed.”

Parmenides: “So, since the one neither partakes of one measure nor many nor few, and does not at all partake of the same, it will never, it seems, be equal to itself or to another, nor again will it be greater or lesser than itself or another.”

Aristoteles: “Entirely so.”

140e

Parmenides: “What about this? Does the one seem capable of being older or younger or the same age as anything?”

Aristoteles: “Why could it not be?”

Parmenides: “Because being the same age as itself or another it would partake of equality of time, and of likeness, and we said that the one does not partake either of likeness or of equality.”

Aristoteles: “We said so indeed.”

Parmenides: “And indeed, we also said that it does not partake of unlikeness and inequality.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, certainly.”

141a

Parmenides: “Well then, since it is like this, in what way can it be older or younger or the same age as anything?”

Aristoteles: “There is no way.”

Parmenides: “So the one could not be younger or older or the same age either as itself or another.”

Aristoteles: “It appears not.”

Parmenides: “Well then, if it were like this, would the one actually be able to be in time at all? Or if something is in time, must it not necessarily be constantly becoming older than itself?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “Isn’t the older always older than the younger?”

Aristoteles: “Indeed.”

141b

Parmenides: “So, whatever is becoming older than itself is also becoming younger than itself at the same time, if indeed it is going to have something to become older than.”

Aristoteles: “How do you mean?”

Parmenides: “As follows. There is no need for something to become different from something else that is already different. Rather, it must already be different from that which is different already, it must have become different from that which has become so, and be about to be different from that which is about to be so. But it must not have become, nor be about to become, nor be different yet, from that which is becoming different. It must be becoming so, and nothing else.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, necessarily.”

141c

Parmenides: “Furthermore, older is difference from younger and not from anything else.”

Aristoteles: “It is indeed.”

Parmenides: “So that which is becoming older than itself is also, necessarily, becoming younger than itself at the same

time.”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

Parmenides: “Then again, it is not becoming so for more or less time than itself. It is rather for a time equal to itself that it becomes, and is, and has become, and is about to be.”

Aristoteles: “This too is necessarily so.”

Parmenides: “So it is necessary, it seems, at least for everything that is in time and partakes of it, that each of them is the same age as itself, and is becoming older than itself and younger than itself at the same time.”

Aristoteles: “Very likely.”

141d

Parmenides: “But of course the one did not share in any of these characteristics.”

Aristoteles: “It did not.”

Parmenides: “Neither then does it have a share of time, nor is it in any time.”

Aristoteles: “It certainly is not, as the argument proves.”

Parmenides: “What about this then? Don’t ‘was’ and ‘has become’ and ‘was becoming’ seem to indicate participation in time that has passed?”

Aristoteles: “They certainly do.”

Parmenides: “And what about ‘will be’ and ‘will become’ and ‘will have become’? Don’t these indicate participation in time to come?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And ‘is’ and ‘becomes’ refer to time that is present now, don’t they?”

Aristoteles: “Entirely so.”

141e

Parmenides: “So if the one does not partake of time in any respect, it has never come into being, nor was it coming into being, and it never was, nor has it now come into being, nor is it coming into being, and it is not. Nor will it come into being in the future, nor will it have come into being, nor will it be.”

Aristoteles: “Very true.”

Parmenides: “Now, is there any way that anything can partake of being besides one of these ways?”

Aristoteles: “There is not.”

Parmenides: “So the one does not partake of being at all.”

Aristoteles: “It seems not.”

Parmenides: “So the one is not, at all.”

142a

Parmenides: “So the one is not, not in such a way as to be one, for if it were it would already be, and be partaking of being. But it seems that the one is not one, and is not, if we should be persuaded by this sort of argument.”

Aristoteles: “Quite likely.”

Parmenides: “What about anything that is not? Would anything be to that, or of that?”

Aristoteles: “No, how could it be?”

Parmenides: “So no name belongs to it, nor an account, nor any knowledge, nor perception, nor opinion.”

Aristoteles: “It appears not.”

Parmenides: “So it is neither named nor described, nor is it subject to opinion, nor is it known, nor is it perceived by any of the things that are.”

Aristoteles: “It seems not.”

Parmenides: “Now, in relation to the one, is it possible that all this is the case?”

Aristoteles: “Well, I don’t think so anyway.”

142b

Parmenides: “Do you wish to go back to the hypothesis once more from the beginning in case something different occurs to us as we go back over it?”

Aristoteles: “I certainly do.”

Parmenides: “In that case, if one is, we are saying that the consequences relating to it, whatever they happen to be, must be agreed upon. Isn’t this so?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Then consider, from the beginning. If one is, can it be but not partake of being?”

Aristoteles: “It cannot.”

Parmenides: “Then there would also be the being of the one, and this is not the same as the one, or else it could not be the being of the one, nor could that, the one, partake of that being, and saying ‘one is’ would be just like saying ‘one is one’. But the present hypothesis is not what must the consequences be ‘if one is one’, but ‘if one is’. Isn’t this so?”

142c

Aristoteles: “It certainly is.”

Parmenides: “Does not the ‘is’ indicate something other than the ‘one’?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “So, whenever someone makes the succinct statement that ‘one is’, this simply means the one partakes of

being.”

Aristoteles: “Entirely so.”

Parmenides: “Then we should again state what the consequences will be if one is. Now, consider this hypothesis. Doesn’t it indicate that the one, being like this, has parts?”

142d

Aristoteles: “How so?”

Parmenides: “As follows. If we speak of the ‘is’ of the one that is, and the ‘one’ of that which is one, but being and one are not the same although both belong to what we hypothesised, namely the one that is, isn’t it necessary that the one that is, itself, be a whole, and that the one and the being constitute parts of this?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “Now, shall we refer to each of these two parts as just a part only, or should the part be referred to as a part of the whole?”

Aristoteles: “Of the whole.”

Parmenides: “So, whatever would be one is a whole and has a part.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

142e

Parmenides: “What about each of these parts of the one that is, the one part and the being part? Is the one ever absent from the being part, or the being from the one part?”

Aristoteles: “It could not be.”

143a

Parmenides: “So, once again, each of the two parts possesses the one and the being, and the least part, in turn, arises from two parts, and according to the same argument it is always the

case that whatever has become a part always possesses these two parts. And so, the one always possesses being and being always possesses the one. And so, of necessity, since it is always becoming two, it is never one.”

Aristoteles: “Entirely so.”

Parmenides: “Consequently, the one that is would be unlimited in multiplicity, would it not?”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

Parmenides: “Let’s take the matter even further.”

Aristoteles: “In what way?”

Parmenides: “Do we maintain that because the one is, it partakes of being?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And for these reasons, the one that is appeared to be many.”

Aristoteles: “Quite so.”

143b

Parmenides: “What about the one itself then, which we maintain partakes of being? If we grasp this in thought, on its own just by itself, without that of which we say it partakes, will it appear to be just one, or will the very same thing also appear to be many?”

Aristoteles: “One. That is what I think anyway.”

Parmenides: “Let’s see. If indeed that one is not being, but as one partakes of being, then its being must necessarily be one thing, and itself something different.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “In that case, if the being is one thing and the one is something different, it is not by being one that the one is different from the being, or by being being that the being is other than the one. Rather they are different from one another by the different and the other.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

143c

Parmenides: “So the different is not the same as the one or the being.”

Aristoteles: “No, how could it be?”

Parmenides: “Well then, if from these we were to select, say, the being and the different, or the being and the one, or the one and the different, would we not be choosing, with each selection, some pair that is correctly referred to as both?”

Aristoteles: “In what way?”

Parmenides: “As follows. Is it possible to mention being?”

Aristoteles: “It is.”

Parmenides: “And also, in turn, to mention one?”

Aristoteles: “This too.”

Parmenides: “In that case, has each of them been mentioned?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And whenever I mention being and one, don’t I mention both?”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

143d

Parmenides: “And whenever I mention being and different, or different and one, and so on for each possible case, don’t I speak of both?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Could things that are correctly referred to as both, be both without being two?”

Aristoteles: “They could not.”

Parmenides: “And if they are two, is there any way that each of them can avoid being one?”

Aristoteles: “None at all.”

Parmenides: “So although each turns out to be a twofold combination of these, each constituent would be one.”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

143e

Parmenides: “And if each of them is one, by combining any one whatsoever with any pair whatsoever, won’t they all become three?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Isn’t three odd and two even?”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “What about this? If there are two, is it not necessary that there is also twice, and if there are three, thrice, if indeed two happens to be twice one and three thrice one?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “And since there are two and twice, isn’t it necessary that there be twice two? And since there are three and thrice, isn’t it necessary, again, that there be thrice three?”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “What about this? If there are three and they are twice, and if there are two and they are thrice, is it not necessary that there be twice three and thrice two?”

Aristoteles: “Very much so.”

144a

Parmenides: “So there would be even times even and odd times odd, and even times odd and odd times even.”

Aristoteles: “This is so.”

Parmenides: “And if this is how matters stand, do you think there is any remaining number which must not necessarily be?”

Aristoteles: “Not at all.”

Parmenides: “So if one is, there must necessarily also be number.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “And yet, if there is number, there would also be many, and a limitless multiplicity of things that are. Or does not number, while being many and partaking of being, become limitless in multiplicity?”

Aristoteles: “Yes, certainly.”

Parmenides: “In that case, if all number partakes of being, would not each part of number also partake of this?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

144b

Parmenides: “So, has being been distributed to all things which are multiple, and is it not absent from any of the things that are, neither from the smallest nor from the largest? Or is this question unreasonable? For how could being be absent from any of the things that are?”

Aristoteles: “In no way at all.”

144c

Parmenides: “So being is chopped up into all sorts of things that are, from the very smallest to the very largest, and is the

most divided of all things, and there are parts without limit, of being.”

Aristoteles: “This is so.”

Parmenides: “So the parts of being are as many as can be.”

Aristoteles: “As many as can be, indeed.”

Parmenides: “What about this? Of these parts, is there any that is a part of being without being one part?”

Aristoteles: “No, how could that ever happen?”

Parmenides: “Rather, I presume, if it actually is, so long as it is, it is necessarily always one thing, it cannot be no thing.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “So the one is present to every part of being, and is not absent from the smaller or larger part, or from anything else.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed so.”

144d

Parmenides: “Well then, being one, is it, as a whole, in many places at the same time? Consider this carefully.”

Aristoteles: “I am considering this, and I see that it is impossible.”

Parmenides: “Then if it is not so as a whole, it is so as divided, for the one will not, I presume, be present at the same time to all the parts of being in any other way besides being divided.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And indeed, whatever is divided must necessarily be as numerous as its parts.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

144e

Parmenides: “So we were not speaking the truth just now when we said that being has been divided more than anything. For it has not been divided more than the one, but, it seems, equally with the one, since being is not absent from the one, nor the one from being, but being two they are always equal throughout everything.”

Aristoteles: “It certainly appears so.”

Parmenides: “So the one, having been itself chopped up by being, is many, and unlimited in multiplicity.”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

Parmenides: “So not alone is the one that is many, but the one itself having been distributed by being, must also of necessity be many.”

Aristoteles: “Entirely so.”

145a

Parmenides: “Furthermore, because the parts are parts of the whole, the one, on the basis of the whole, would be limited. Or are the parts not contained by the whole?”

Aristoteles: “They must be.”

Parmenides: “And yet whatever contains would be a limit.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “So the one, being one, is presumably also many, and a whole, and parts, and is limited and limitless in multiplicity.”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

Parmenides: “In which case, since it is limited, doesn’t it also have extremities?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “What about this? If it is a whole, would it not also have a beginning, middle and end? Or can anything be a whole without these three? And if any one of these is missing from anything, will it still, of itself, be a whole?”

145b

Aristoteles: “Not of itself, no.”

Parmenides: “Then the one, it seems, would also have a beginning, an end and a middle?”

Aristoteles: “It would.”

Parmenides: “Now, the middle stands equally between the extremities, for otherwise it would not be a middle.”

Aristoteles: “It would not.”

Parmenides: “Then being like this, the one would also partake of some shape, either straight or round or some mixture of both.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, it would partake of this.”

Parmenides: “Now, since this is so, won’t it also be in itself and in another?”

Aristoteles: “How so?”

Parmenides: “Each of the parts is presumably in the whole, and none are outside the whole.”

Aristoteles: “Quite so.”

145c

Parmenides: “Are all the parts contained by the whole?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And indeed, the one is all the parts of itself and neither more nor less than all.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “The one is also the whole, is it not?”

Aristoteles: “How could it not be?”

Parmenides: “So, if all the parts happen to be in the whole, and the one is all the parts and the whole itself, and all the parts are contained by the whole, the one would be contained by the one, and the one would itself, in this way, already be in itself.”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

145d

Parmenides: “Then again, the whole, in turn, is not in any of the parts, nor in them all. For if it is in them all, it must be in one, since without being in any one it would not, presumably, be in them all. And if this one is one of them all, and the whole is not present in this, how will it still be present in them all?”

Aristoteles: “In no way at all.”

Parmenides: “Nor again is it in some of the parts, for if the whole were in some, more would be in less, which is impossible.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, impossible.”

145e

Parmenides: “But if the whole is not in more, or in one, or in all of the parts, must it not necessarily be in something different, or no longer be anywhere at all?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “Now, being nowhere it would be nothing, but being a whole, since it is not in itself, it is necessarily in another.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “Insofar then as the one is a whole, it is in another, whereas insofar as it happens to be all the parts, it is in itself, and thus the one must itself be in itself, and in another.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “So, if this is the nature of the one, must it not necessarily be in motion and at rest?”

Aristoteles: “In what way?”

146a

Parmenides: “If it is indeed in itself it is presumably at rest, for being in one and not changing from that, it would be in the same, in itself.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed so.”

Parmenides: “And that which is always in the same must, surely, always be at rest.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “What about this? Is it not necessarily the case, in contrast, that whatever is always in the different must never be in the same, and never being in the same must never be at rest, and never being at rest must be moving?”

Aristoteles: “Quite so.”

Parmenides: “So, is it necessary that the one, because it is always in itself and in something different, is always in motion and at rest?”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

146b

Parmenides: “And indeed, if it is actually characterised as just indicated, it must be the same as itself and different from itself, and in like manner be both the same as and different from the others.”

Aristoteles: “How so?”

Parmenides: “Everything is presumably related to everything else as follows. It is either the same or different, and if it were

neither the same nor different, it would be related to this, either as part to whole, or as whole in relation to part.”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

Parmenides: “Now, is the one itself part of itself?”

Aristoteles: “Not at all.”

Parmenides: “So it would not be related as a whole to itself as part of itself.”

Aristoteles: “No, it could not be.”

146c

Parmenides: “But is the one different from one?”

Aristoteles: “Of course not.”

Parmenides: “So it would not be different from itself.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “Now, if it is neither related to itself as different, nor as part, nor whole, must it not then necessarily be the same as itself?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

146d

Parmenides: “What about this? Is it not necessary that whatever is in something different from itself, itself being in the same as itself, must be different from itself, if indeed it is also to be in something different?”

Aristoteles: “Well, I think so.”

Parmenides: “And this appeared to be the case with the one, being both in itself and in another at the same time.”

Aristoteles: “It appeared so indeed.”

Parmenides: “So the one, it seems, would in this way be different from itself.”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

Parmenides: “What about this? If anything is different from something, will it not be different from something that is different?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “Won’t whatever is not one be different from the one, and the one from whatever is not one?”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “So the one would be different from the others?”

Aristoteles: “Different.”

146e

Parmenides: “Now, look at this. Are not the same itself and the different opposite to one another?”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “In that case will the same ever, of itself, be in the different, or the different be in the same?”

Aristoteles: “Not of itself, no.”

Parmenides: “So, if the different will never be in the same, there are none of the things that are in which the different will be present for any time, for if the different were in anything for any time, the different would for that time be in the same. Is this not so?”

Aristoteles: “It is so.”

Parmenides: “And since the different is never in the same, it would never be in any of the things that are.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

Parmenides: “So the different would not be in things not one, nor in the one.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

147a

Parmenides: “So, not by the different would the one be different from things not one, nor things not one from the one.”

Aristoteles: “No.”

Parmenides: “Nor by themselves could they be different from one another, since they do not partake of the different.”

Aristoteles: “No, how could they?”

Parmenides: “And if they are not different by themselves, nor by the different, wouldn’t they totally avoid being different from one another?”

Aristoteles: “They would.”

Parmenides: “Furthermore, things not one do not partake of the one, or else they would not be not one, but would somehow be one.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

Parmenides: “Neither would things not one be number, for in this way they would not be not one in every respect, because they would at least have number.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed.”

147b

Parmenides: “What about this? Are things not one parts of the one, or in that case too would things not one partake of the one?”

Aristoteles: “They would partake of it.”

Parmenides: “So, if in every respect the one is one, and they are not one, the one would neither be a part of things not one, nor a whole with them as its parts. Nor again would things not one be parts of the one, nor wholes with the one as a part.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “And indeed, we said that things that are neither parts, nor wholes, nor different from one another, will be the same as one another.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, we said so.”

147c

Parmenides: “Then, should we also say that the one, being related in this way to things not one, is the same as them?”

Aristoteles: “We should say so.”

Parmenides: “So the one, it seems, is different both from the others and from itself, and also the same as them, and itself.”

Aristoteles: “It certainly appears likely from this argument.”

Parmenides: “Now, is it also like and unlike itself and the others?”

Aristoteles: “Perhaps.”

Parmenides: “Well, since it appeared to be different from the others, the others too will presumably be different from it.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed.”

Parmenides: “Wouldn’t it then be just as different from the others as the others are from it, neither more nor less?”

Aristoteles: “Yes, it would.”

Parmenides: “So, if it is neither more so nor less so, it is so in like manner.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Now, being characterised as different from the others, and the others as different from the one in like manner, the one would in this respect be characterised as the same as the others, and the others as the same as the one.”

147d

Aristoteles: “How do you mean?”

Parmenides: “As follows. Don’t you apply each of the names you use to something?”

Aristoteles: “I do.”

Parmenides: “Yes, and can you speak the same name once or many times?”

Aristoteles: “I can.”

Parmenides: “Now, is it the case that when you say the name once, you refer to that of which it is the name, whereas you don’t refer to that when you say it many times? Or is there a strong necessity that you always speak of the same thing, whether you say the same name once or many times?”

Aristoteles: “Indeed so.”

Parmenides: “Now, ‘different’ is a name given to something, is it not?”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

147e

Parmenides: “So whenever you utter it, whether once or many times, you are not referring to something else, or naming anything else apart from that of which it is the name.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “Then, whenever we say that the others are different from the one and that the one is different from the others, we say ‘different’ twice, but we are not applying the word to another nature. We are always referring to that nature of which it is the name.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

148a

Parmenides: “So, insofar as the one is different from the others and the others from the one, on the basis of being characterised as different, the one would have a characteristic that is not other than the others but is the same. And whatever somehow has a characteristic the same, is like, is it not?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Insofar then as the one is characterised as different from the others, it would on that basis be entirely like them all, since it is entirely different from them all.”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

148b

Parmenides: “And yet the like is opposite to the unlike.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And the different too is opposite to the same.”

Aristoteles: “It is.”

Parmenides: “Then again it appeared to be the case that the one is the same as the others.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, it appeared so.”

Parmenides: “And yet being the same as the others is the characteristic opposite to being different from the others.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “But, at least insofar as it was different, it appeared to be like.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “So, insofar as it is the same, it will be unlike based upon the characteristic opposite to the one by which it was characterised as like. And the different made it like, I presume?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

148c

Parmenides: “So the same will make it unlike, or else it will not be opposite to the different.”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

Parmenides: “So the one will be like and unlike the others, being like insofar as it is different, and unlike insofar as it is the same.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, it seems that such an argument as this also holds.”

Parmenides: “And indeed the following holds too.”

Aristoteles: “Which is?”

Parmenides: “Insofar as it has a characteristic that is the same, it has a characteristic that is not of another kind; and having a characteristic that is not of another kind, it is not unlike; and not being unlike, it is like. Whereas insofar as it has another characteristic, it is of another kind, and being of another kind, is unlike.”

Aristoteles: “That’s true.”

148d

Parmenides: “So the one, being the same as the others and because it is different, on both grounds and on either ground, would be both like and unlike the others.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “In relation to itself too, in like manner, since it appeared to be different from itself and the same as itself, on both grounds and on either, it will prove to be both like and unlike itself.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “What about this? Consider the question of the one touching and not touching itself and the others.”

Aristoteles: “I am.”

Parmenides: “Indeed, the one somehow appeared to be in itself as a whole.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

Parmenides: “Now, won’t the one also be in the others?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

148e

Parmenides: “Then, insofar as it is in the others, it would touch the others, while insofar as it is in itself, it would be prevented from touching the others, and being in itself, would touch itself.”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

Parmenides: “Thus the one, then, would touch both itself and the others.”

Aristoteles: “It would.”

Parmenides: “What about this then? Mustn’t everything that is going to touch something lie next to whatever it is going to touch, occupying the position that lies alongside the position occupied by whatever it touches?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “So the one then, if it is going to touch itself, must lie right next to itself, occupying a place adjacent to the place that itself is in.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, it must do this.”

149a

Parmenides: “Now, the one could do this by being two. It could then be in two places at the same time. But as long as it is one,

how could it do so of itself?"

Aristoteles: "It could not."

Parmenides: "So by the same necessity that makes it the case that the one is not two, it must not touch itself either."

Aristoteles: "The same."

Parmenides: "Nor indeed will it touch the others."

Aristoteles: "Why is that?"

Parmenides: "Because, according to us, whatever is going to touch must be separate from and next to whatever it will touch, without any third thing in between them."

Aristoteles: "True."

Parmenides: "So, if there is to be contact, there must be at least two things."

Aristoteles: "There must."

149b

Parmenides: "And if to the two, the two distinct things, a third is added next to them, they will be three, and the contacts two."

Aristoteles: "Yes."

Parmenides: "And in this way then, by continually adding one thing, one contact is also added, and it follows that the contacts are fewer by one than the quantity of numbers. For by whatever the first two exceed the contacts, in being more in a number than the contacts, any succeeding number also exceeds all the contacts by an amount equal to this. For with every remaining addition, one is added to the number and one contact is added to the contacts at the same time."

149c

Aristoteles: "Correct."

Parmenides: “So, whatever the number of things that are, the contacts are always one fewer than them.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

Parmenides: “And yet if there is only one, and there is no two, there could be no contact.”

Aristoteles: “No, how could there be?”

Parmenides: “Now, according to us, things other than one are neither one, nor do they partake of it if they are indeed other.”

Aristoteles: “No indeed.”

Parmenides: “So number is not in the others since one is not in them.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly not.”

149d

Parmenides: “So the others are neither one nor two, nor do they possess the name of any other number.”

Aristoteles: “They do not.”

Parmenides: “So the one alone is one, and there could not be two.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently not.”

Parmenides: “And in the absence of two, there is no contact.”

Aristoteles: “There is not.”

Parmenides: “So the one does not touch the others nor the others the one, since there is no contact.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “Accordingly, on the basis of all this, the one both touches and does not touch itself and the others.”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

Parmenides: “Well then, is the one also equal and unequal both to itself and to the others?”

Aristoteles: “In what way?”

149e

Parmenides: “If the one were greater or lesser than the others, or the others for their part were greater or lesser than the one, they could not be greater or lesser than one another by their own being, by the one being one and the others being other than one, could they? But if in addition to being like this each were to possess equality, they would be equal to one another. But if the others had greatness while the one had smallness, or the one had greatness while the others had smallness, whatever form had greatness added to it would be greater, while that to which smallness was added would be lesser.”

150a

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “So there are these two forms, largeness and smallness, are there not? For if somehow there were not, they could not be opposite to one another, nor could they occur in things that are.”

Aristoteles: “No, how could they?”

Parmenides: “Now, if smallness occurs in the one, it would be present either in the whole or in part of it.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “What if it were to occur in the whole? Wouldn’t it either be extended equally throughout the whole of the one, or else encompass it?”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

150b

Parmenides: “Now, smallness, by being equally with the one, would be equal to it, while by encompassing the one, wouldn’t it

be greater than the one?"

Aristoteles: "Inevitably."

Parmenides: "Now, can smallness be equal to or greater than something, and do what belongs to equality or to greatness rather than what belongs to itself?"

Aristoteles: "Impossible."

Parmenides: "So smallness could not be in the one as a whole, but in part, if so at all."

Aristoteles: "Yes."

Parmenides: "But not in the entire part, otherwise it will act in the same way as it did towards the whole. It will either be equal to or greater than whatever part it would always be in."

Aristoteles: "Necessarily."

150c

Parmenides: "So smallness will never be in any of the things that are, since it occurs neither in a part nor in the whole, nor will anything be small except smallness itself."

Aristoteles: "It seems not."

Parmenides: "So largeness will not be in the one either, for in that case, besides largeness itself, something else, whatever largeness was in, would be larger, and that would happen in the absence of the small, which the larger necessarily exceeds if it is actually to be large. But this is impossible since smallness is not in anything anywhere."

Aristoteles: "True."

150d

Parmenides: "Furthermore, largeness itself is not larger than anything except smallness itself, nor is smallness less than anything but largeness itself."

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “So the others are neither greater nor lesser than the one, since they possess neither greatness nor smallness. Nor do these two themselves possess the power of exceeding and being exceeded in relation to the one, but only in relation to one another. Nor again would the one be greater or lesser than these two or the others, since it possesses neither greatness nor smallness.”

Aristoteles: “It certainly appears not.”

Parmenides: “Now, if the one is neither greater nor lesser than the others, must it necessarily neither exceed them nor be exceeded by them?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

150e

Parmenides: “Now, that which neither exceeds nor is exceeded must necessarily be equally so, and being equally so, must be equal.”

Aristoteles: “Inevitably.”

Parmenides: “And indeed the one itself would also be related in this way to itself, having neither largeness nor smallness in itself, it would neither exceed nor be exceeded by itself, but being equally so, it would be equal to itself.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, certainly.”

Parmenides: “So the one would be equal to itself and the others.”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

151a

Parmenides: “And indeed the one, because it is in itself, would surround itself from outside, and by encompassing itself would be greater than itself, while by being encompassed it would be

lesser than itself, and thus the one would be greater than and lesser than itself.”

Aristoteles: “It would indeed.”

Parmenides: “Is it necessary then, that outside of the one and the others, there is nothing?”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “And yet what is, must always be somewhere.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Won’t whatever is in something, be so as a lesser in a greater? For in no other way could one thing be in another.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

151b

Parmenides: “But since there is nothing else apart from the others and the one, and since they must be in something, mustn’t they necessarily then be in one another, the others in the one and the one in the others, or else be nowhere at all?”

Aristoteles: “Apparently so.”

Parmenides: “So, because the one is in the others, the others would be greater than the one since they encompass it, while the one, since it is encompassed, would be lesser than the others. But because the others are in the one, the one would, by the same argument, be greater than the others and the others lesser than the one.”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

Parmenides: “So the one is both equal to, and greater and lesser than, itself and the others.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently.”

151c

Parmenides: “And indeed, if it is actually greater, and lesser, and equal, it would be of equal measures with itself and the others, and of more and fewer measures too, and since of measures, also of parts.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “Then being of equal measures and more and less, it would also be less and more in number than itself and the others, and equal both to itself and the others on the same basis.”

Aristoteles: “In what way?”

Parmenides: “It would presumably be of more measures and parts than whatever it is greater than, and of as many parts as of measures, and likewise for whatever it is less than, and the same holds for whatever it is equal to.”

Aristoteles: “Quite so.”

151d

Parmenides: “Then being greater and lesser than and equal to itself, wouldn’t it be of equal and more and fewer measures to itself, and since of measures, also of parts?”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “Well then, being of equal parts with itself, it would be equal to itself in multiplicity, and being more than itself and less than itself, it would be more or less in number than itself.”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

Parmenides: “Wouldn’t the one also relate to the others in the same way? Because it appears greater than them, it is necessarily more than them in number, and on the other hand, because it is smaller it is less in number, and because it appears equal in magnitude, it must be equal in multiplicity to the

others.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

151e

Parmenides: “Accordingly, it seems that the one will in turn be equal to, and more and less in number than itself and the others.”

Aristoteles: “It will.”

152a

Parmenides: “Now, does the one partake of time, and partaking of time, is it and does it come to be younger and older than itself and the others, and neither younger nor older than itself and the others?”

Aristoteles: “How?”

Parmenides: “If one actually is, then ‘to be’ belongs to it.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And is ‘to be’ anything other than participation in being along with present time, just as ‘was’ is communion with being along with past time, and ‘will be’ is communion along with future time.”

Aristoteles: “It is indeed.”

Parmenides: “So the one partakes of time if it does indeed partake of being.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “Of time that is advancing?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

152b

Parmenides: “So the one continually becomes older than itself if it actually advances according to time.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “Now, do we remember that whatever becomes older becomes older than something that becomes younger?”

Aristoteles: “We do.”

Parmenides: “Therefore, since the one becomes older than itself, wouldn’t it become older while becoming younger than itself?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “In this way then, it becomes younger and older than itself.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

152c

Parmenides: “But it is actually older, is it not, whenever in coming to be it is at the present moment, in between what was and what will be? For as it proceeds from what was to what will be, it will not, I presume, step over the present.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “Well, won’t it then cease from becoming older whenever it encounters the present? Then it is not becoming older since it is already older. For while advancing it would never be grasped by the present. For that which is advancing is in a situation whereby it is in touch with both the present and what will be, letting go of the present while grasping what will be, as it is becoming in between both what will be and the present.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

152d

Parmenides: “But if anything that is becoming must necessarily not evade the present, then whenever it is, at this it ceases from its becoming, and then actually is whatever it happened to be becoming.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently.”

Parmenides: “And so the one, as it is becoming older, ceases becoming older and is actually older whenever, as it is becoming older, it encounters the present.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, certainly.”

Parmenides: “Now, it is actually older than whatever it was becoming older than, and wasn’t it becoming older than itself?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Is the older, older than the younger?”

Aristoteles: “It is.”

Parmenides: “And so the one is then younger than itself whenever, as it is becoming older, it encounters the present.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

152e

Parmenides: “And yet, the present is always present to the one throughout its entire being, for whenever the one is, it always is in the present.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “So the one always is, and always becomes, older and younger than itself.”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

Parmenides: “Now, is it, or is it becoming, for a longer time than itself, or for an equal time?”

Aristoteles: “Equal.”

Parmenides: “But whatever is always becoming for an equal time is the same age.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “And whatever is the same age is neither younger nor older.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed.”

Parmenides: “Then the one, since it is and is becoming for a time that is equal to itself, neither is nor is becoming, younger or older than itself.”

Aristoteles: “It seems not.”

Parmenides: “Well then, what about the others?”

Aristoteles: “I can’t say.”

153a

Parmenides: “Well, you can say that things other than the one, if they are indeed things that are different rather than a thing that is different, are more than one. For a different thing would be one, while different things are more than one and would be possessed of multiplicity.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, they would.”

Parmenides: “And being multiple they would have a share of number greater than the one.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “What about this? Shall we maintain, with respect to number, that it is the more numerous or the less numerous that come into being, and have come into being earlier?”

Aristoteles: “The less numerous.”

153b

Parmenides: “So the least of all is first of all and this is the one. Isn’t this so?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “So, of everything that possesses number, the one has come into being first, and the others all possess number if

they are indeed others, and not just an other.”

Aristoteles: “They possess it indeed.”

Parmenides: “But the one, I think, having come into being first, has come into being earlier, while the others have come into being later, and thus the others would be younger than the one and the one older than the others.”

Aristoteles: “They would indeed.”

153c

Parmenides: “What about this? Has the one come into being contrary to its own nature, or is that an impossibility?”

Aristoteles: “An impossibility.”

Parmenides: “And yet the one was shown to have parts, and having parts, to have a beginning, an end and a middle.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Now, of all the parts of the one itself, and of each of the others, doesn’t the beginning come into being first, and after the beginning, all the others until the end?”

Aristoteles: “Indeed.”

Parmenides: “And shall we also say that all these others are parts of the whole, that is the one, and that this has itself come to be one and whole, simultaneously with the end?”

Aristoteles: “Yes, so we should say that.”

153d

Parmenides: “And yet the end, I believe, comes into being last, and simultaneously with this, the one naturally comes into being. So that if indeed the one itself necessarily comes into being in accord with its nature, it would naturally come into being later than the others, having come into being at the same time as the end.”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

Parmenides: “So the one is younger than the others, and things other than the one are older than the one.”

Aristoteles: “Again, that’s how it appears to me.”

Parmenides: “What about the beginning then, or any other part whatsoever of the one or of anything else at all? If it is a part, but is not parts, must it not of necessity be one, at least insofar as it is a part?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

153e

Parmenides: “In that case the one would come into being at the same time as the first part that comes into being, and at the same time as the second, and is not left out of any of the other parts that come into being, whatever is added to anything, until, with the arrival of the last part, one whole has come into being, missing neither the middle part, nor the first, nor the last, nor any other part, in its generation.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

154a

Parmenides: “Therefore, the one is the same age as all the others, and so, if the one itself is not by nature opposed to its own nature, it would not have come into being either before or after the others, but at the same time. And according to this account, the one would be neither older nor younger than the others, nor the others than the one. But according to the previous argument the one is both older and younger than the others, and the others are in like manner both older and younger than the one.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, certainly.”

Parmenides: “So the one is, and has come into being in this way. But what about the one becoming both older and younger

than the others, and the others than the one, and becoming neither older nor younger? Is whatever is the case in relation to being also the case in relation to becoming, or is it different?"

Aristoteles: "I cannot say."

154b

Parmenides: "Well, I can say this much at least. If one thing is indeed older than another, it would not be able to become even older by an age difference greater than the age difference when it first came into being, nor for its part could the younger become even younger by an increased amount. For equal amounts added to unequal amounts of time, or anything else at all, always make them differ by an amount equal to the initial difference."

Aristoteles: "Of course."

Parmenides: "So that which is older or younger could never become older or younger if it does indeed always differ in age by an equal amount. It is, and has come to be, older in one case and younger in the other, but it is not becoming older or younger."

Aristoteles: "True."

154c

Parmenides: "Then the one does not ever become either older or younger than the others that are older or younger than it."

Aristoteles: "Indeed not."

Parmenides: "But let's see if they become older or younger in the following way."

Aristoteles: "How?"

Parmenides: "In the way that the one appeared to be older than the others, and the others than the one."

Aristoteles: "What of it?"

Parmenides: “Whenever the one is older than the others, it has been becoming for a longer period of time than the others.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

154d

Parmenides: “Consider this, then. If we add an equal amount of time to the greater and to the lesser time periods, will the greater differ from the lesser by an equal portion of time, or by a smaller portion?”

Aristoteles: “By a smaller portion.”

Parmenides: “So, whatever was the initial age difference between the one and the others, this will not be the same thereafter. Rather, having taken a time increment that is equal to the others, the one will always differ from them by a lesser portion than before. Isn’t this so?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

154e

Parmenides: “Now, wouldn’t that which is lesser in age than it was before in relation to something else, become younger than before in relation to whatever it was previously older than?”

Aristoteles: “Yes, younger.”

Parmenides: “And if that becomes younger, won’t those others, in turn, become older than before in relation to the one?”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

155a

Parmenides: “So that which has come to be younger, becomes younger in relation to that which had previously come to be and still is older, yet although it is always becoming older than that, it never actually is older. For that advances towards the younger, while the younger advances towards the older. And the older, for its part, becomes younger than the younger in the very same way. For as they are both proceeding towards their

opposites, they are becoming opposite to one another; the younger is becoming older than the older, while the older is becoming younger than the younger. But they could not actually become so. For if they had become so, they would no longer be becoming so, but would actually be so. But as matters stand, they are becoming older and younger than one another; the one is becoming younger than the others because it proved to be older and to have come into being earlier, while the others are becoming older than the one because they came into being later. And by the same argument, the others are also related in the same way to the one, since they proved to be older than the one and to have come into being earlier.”

155b

Aristoteles: “Yes, this appears to be the case.”

155c

Parmenides: “Isn’t it the case then, that in so far as nothing becomes younger or older than anything else on the basis of always differing by an equal number, the one would not become older or younger than the others, nor the others than the one. While insofar as things that have come into being earlier necessarily differ from things that have come into being later, and the later from the earlier, by a portion that is never the same, things must in this way be becoming both older and younger than one another, the others than the one, and the one than the others?”

Aristoteles: “Yes, certainly.”

Parmenides: “Based upon all this then, the one is itself both older and younger than the others, and is becoming so, and neither is, nor is becoming, either older or younger than itself or the others.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, entirely so.”

155d

Parmenides: “And since the one partakes of time and of becoming older and younger, mustn’t it necessarily partake of ‘was’, ‘will be’, and of ‘now’, if it does indeed partake of time?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “So the one was, and is, and will be, and has become, and is becoming, and will become.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed.”

Parmenides: “And something could be to that, and of that, and was, and is, and will be.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “And there could then be knowledge of this, and opinion, and awareness, if we are in fact even now engaging in all these in relation to this.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

155e

Parmenides: “And a name and an account belong to it, and it is named and described, and anything of this sort that happens to apply to the others applies also to the one.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, this is how matters stand, entirely so.”

Parmenides: “Then, let’s say for yet a third time: if the one is, as we have described it, being both one and many, and neither one nor many, and partaking of time, must it not of necessity sometimes partake of being because one is, and, indeed, sometimes not partake of being because one is not?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “Now, when it is partaking will it then be able not to partake, or to partake when it is not partaking?”

Aristoteles: “It will not be able.”

156a

Parmenides: “So it partakes at one time and does not partake at another, for only in this way could it partake and not partake of the same thing.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

Parmenides: “Isn’t there also this time when it gets a share of being and gets rid of it? Or how will it be able to have something at one time, and not have the same thing at another, if it does not ever take hold of this and let it go?”

Aristoteles: “In no way at all.”

Parmenides: “Well don’t you refer to getting a share of being as coming to be?”

Aristoteles: “I do.”

Parmenides: “And to departing from being as ceasing to be?”

Aristoteles: “Yes, indeed.”

Parmenides: “Then the one, it seems, in grasping and letting go of being, is coming into being and ceasing to be.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

156b

Parmenides: “And being both one and many, and coming into being and ceasing to be, isn’t it the case that whenever it becomes one, its being many ceases to be, and whenever it becomes many, its being one ceases to be.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “And in becoming one and many mustn’t it necessarily be separated and combined?”

Aristoteles: “Very much so.”

Parmenides: “And indeed whenever it becomes unlike and like, mustn’t it necessarily be likened and unlikened?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And whenever it becomes greater or lesser or equal, isn’t it increased, diminished or equalised?”

Aristoteles: “Quite so.”

156c

Parmenides: “And whenever being in motion it comes to rest, and whenever being at rest it changes to moving, it must not itself be in any time at all.”

Aristoteles: “How so?”

Parmenides: “Being previously at rest and afterwards in motion, or previously in motion and subsequently at rest, are impossible unless it undergoes change.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “And yet there is no time in which something can, simultaneously, be neither in motion nor at rest.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “But it cannot undergo change without changing.”

Aristoteles: “Not likely.”

156d

Parmenides: “So when does it undergo change? For it does not change whilst at rest, or whilst in motion, or whilst in time.”

Aristoteles: “It does not.”

Parmenides: “Well, in that case, is there this strange thing in which it would then be when it changes?”

Aristoteles: “What sort of thing?”

156e

Parmenides: “The moment. Indeed the moment seems to indicate something of this sort, such that there is change from

the moment to either state. For a thing does not change from resting while still being at rest, nor does it change from moving while still being in motion. But the moment is this strange nature, inserted between motion and rest, being in no time at all, and indeed to this, and from this, the moving changes to being at rest and the resting to being in motion.”

Aristoteles: “Quite likely.”

157a

Parmenides: “And the one then, if indeed it is both at rest and in motion, would change to both states, for only in this way could it do both. But in changing it changes in a moment, and when it changes it would be in no time at all, nor would it then be in motion, nor would it be at rest.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “Is this also the case in relation to the other changes? Whenever it changes from being to ceasing to be, or from not being to coming into being, is it then coming to be in between certain motions and rests? And is it then the case that it neither is, nor is not, and is neither coming to be, nor ceasing to be?”

Aristoteles: “So it seems at any rate.”

157b

Parmenides: “And by the same argument too, when going from one to many and from many to one, it is neither one nor many, neither separated nor combined. And when going from like to unlike and from unlike to like, it is neither like nor unlike, neither likened nor unlikened. When going from small to large, and to equal, and to their opposites, it is neither small nor large nor equal, and it would be neither increasing nor diminishing nor becoming equal.”

Aristoteles: “It seems not.”

Parmenides: “So, if the one is, it would undergo all these affections.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “Well, shouldn’t we also consider what it would be appropriate for the others to undergo if one is?”

Aristoteles: “We should consider this.”

Parmenides: “In that case, should we state what things other than the one must undergo, if one is?”

Aristoteles: “We should.”

157c

Parmenides: “Now, since they are indeed other than the one, the others are not the one, or else they would not be other than the one.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

Parmenides: “But the others are not entirely deprived of the one either, but partake of it in some way.”

Aristoteles: “In what way?”

Parmenides: “Things other than the one are presumably other because they have parts. Indeed if they were not to have parts they would be entirely one.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

Parmenides: “But parts, we say, are parts of this, this whole.”

Aristoteles: “So we say.”

Parmenides: “And yet the whole is necessarily one composed of many, of which the parts will be parts, for each of the parts must be a part not of multiplicities but of a whole.”

Aristoteles: “Why is that?”

157d

Parmenides: “If something were to be a part of a multiplicity, among which it is itself included, it would presumably be part of itself which is impossible. And it would be a part of each of the others too if it were actually part of them all. Indeed, not being part of this one, it will be a part of the others except for this one, and thus will not be part of each one, but not being part of each it will be part of none of the many. But it is not possible for something that is not a part of all of them to be a part or anything else at all of those things of which it is not a part of any one.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently so.”

157e

Parmenides: “So a part is not a part of a multiplicity or of all; it is rather a part of some one form that we call a whole, a complete one that has arisen from them all. A part would be part of this.”

Aristoteles: “Entirely so.”

Parmenides: “So, if the others have parts, they would also have a share of the one and of the whole.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “So things other than one must necessarily be one complete whole possessing parts.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

158a

Parmenides: “And indeed, the same argument applies to each part. For these too must necessarily have a share of the one. For if each of them is a part, being each presumably indicates being distinct from the others and being by itself, if indeed it is to be each.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

Parmenides: “And yet it would of course have a share of the one while being other than one, or else it would not have a share of the one but would itself be one. But it is presumably impossible now for anything except the one itself to be one.”

Aristoteles: “Impossible.”

Parmenides: “So both the whole and the part necessarily share in the one. For the whole will be one and the parts will be parts of that. While each part, in turn, that is part of the whole, would be one part of the whole.”

Aristoteles: “Quite so.”

158b

Parmenides: “Won’t whatever shares in the one have a share while being different from the one?”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “Things that are different from the one would presumably be many. Indeed if things other than the one were neither one nor more than one, they would be nothing.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed so.”

Parmenides: “But since whatever gets a share of one part or one whole is more than one, it is necessary, is it not, that those things themselves that partake of the one must already be unlimited in multiplicity?”

Aristoteles: “How so?”

158c

Parmenides: “Let’s look at the following. When they partake of the one they partake while neither being one, nor having a share of the one.”

Aristoteles: “Obviously.”

Parmenides: “Then they partake, don’t they, while being multiplicities in which the one is not present?”

Aristoteles: “Multiplicities indeed.”

Parmenides: “What about this? If we wished, in thought, to take away as little as we possibly could from such multiplicities, wouldn’t the part that has been taken away necessarily be a multiplicity and not one, if in fact it does not partake of the one?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “Now, continuing to consider the nature just by itself, different from the form, in this way won’t as much of it as we can ever discern be unlimited in multiplicity?”

Aristoteles: “Entirely so.”

158d

Parmenides: “And indeed, whenever each part has become one part, the parts then have limit in relation to one another, and in relation to the whole, and so too does the whole in relation to the parts.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, exactly.”

Parmenides: “In that case, the consequence for things other than the one from the communion of themselves and the one is, it seems, that something different arises among themselves which provides limit in relation to one another, while by themselves their own nature provides limitlessness.”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

Parmenides: “In this way then, things other than the one, both as wholes, or based upon parts, are limitless and have a share of limit.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

158e

Parmenides: “Are they not also both like and unlike one another and themselves?”

Aristoteles: “In what way?”

Parmenides: “Insofar as they are all presumably unlimited based upon their own nature, they would in this way be characterised as the same.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “And indeed, insofar as they all have a share of limit, they would all in this way also be characterised as the same.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

159a

Parmenides: “And yet insofar as they have been characterised as both limited and limitless, they have been characterised by characteristics that are opposite to one another.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And the opposites are as unlike as possible.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed.”

Parmenides: “So on the basis of either characteristic, they would be like themselves and one another, while on the basis of both characteristics, they would be as unlike as possible, and as opposite as possible, in both ways.”

Aristoteles: “Quite likely.”

Parmenides: “In this way then, the others themselves would be both like and unlike themselves and one another.”

Aristoteles: “So they would.”

159b

Parmenides: “And since they actually proved to have these characteristics, we shall find with no further difficulty that things other than the one are the same as, and different from, one another, are in motion and at rest, and are characterised by

all the opposite characteristics.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

Parmenides: “Well then, if at this stage we accept these outcomes as obvious, should we consider once more if one is, are things other than the one not so, or just so?”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “Then let us say from the beginning how things other than the one must be characterised if one is.”

Aristoteles: “Let’s say so.”

Parmenides: “Now, must not the one be separate from the others, and the others be separate from the one?”

Aristoteles: “Why is that?”

159c

Parmenides: “Because there is not, I presume, anything else besides these, that is other than the one and other than the others, for once the one and the others have been mentioned, everything has been spoken of.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, everything.”

Parmenides: “So there is nothing further that is different from these, in which both the one and the others could be in the same.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “So the one and the others are never in the same.”

Aristoteles: “It seems not.”

Parmenides: “So are they separate?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Now, according to us that which is truly one does not have parts.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “So the one as a whole, would not be in the others, nor would parts of it, if it is separate from the others and does not have parts.”

159d

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “So the others would not partake of the one in any way, since they partake neither of a part of it nor of the whole.”

Aristoteles: “It seems not.”

Parmenides: “So the others are not one in any way, nor do they have any one in themselves.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “So the others are not many either, for each of them would be one part of the whole if they were many. But, as matters stand, things other than one are neither one nor many, neither a whole nor parts, since they do not partake of the one in any way.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

159e

Parmenides: “So the others themselves are neither two nor three nor are these in them if they are indeed entirely deprived of the one.”

Aristoteles: “This is so.”

Parmenides: “So the others are themselves neither like and unlike the one, nor are likeness and unlikeness in them. For if they were like and unlike, or had likeness and unlikeness in themselves, things other than the one would presumably possess two forms in themselves that are opposite to one another.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently.”

Parmenides: “But things that do not even partake of one could not possibly partake of any two.”

Aristoteles: “Impossible.”

Parmenides: “So the others are neither like, nor unlike, nor both. For if they were like or unlike they would partake of one different form, and if they were both like and unlike they would partake of two opposite forms, but these outcomes have proved to be impossible.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

160a

Parmenides: “Nor are they the same or different, nor are they in motion or at rest, nor are they coming into being or ceasing to be, nor are they greater or lesser or equal. Nor do they have any other characteristics of this sort. For if the others submit to being characterised by anything of this sort, they will also share in one and two and three and odd and even. But it turned out to be impossible for them to partake of these since they are entirely deprived of the one in every way.”

Aristoteles: “Very true.”

160b

Parmenides: “In which case, if one is, the one is everything, and both in relation to itself and in relation to the others in like manner, it is not even one.”

Aristoteles: “Entirely so.”

Parmenides: “So be it. Next, should we not consider what the consequences must be if one is not?”

Aristoteles: “Yes, we should.”

Parmenides: “Well, what would this hypothesis, ‘if one is not’, be? Does it differ at all from the hypothesis, ‘if not one is not’?”

Aristoteles: “It differs indeed.”

Parmenides: “Does it just differ, or is saying ‘if not one is not’ the complete opposite to saying ‘if one is not’?”

Aristoteles: “It is the complete opposite.”

160c

Parmenides: “What if someone were to say ‘if largeness is not’ or ‘if smallness is not’, or anything else of that sort, would it be obvious in each case that he is saying that a different thing is that which is not?”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “Is it not also obvious then that whenever someone says ‘if one is not’, he is saying that what is not is different from the others, and we know what he is referring to?”

Aristoteles: “Yes, we know.”

Parmenides: “So whenever he speaks of one, is it obvious, firstly, that he is referring to something knowable, and secondly, to something different from the others, whether being or not being is added. For we still know, nevertheless, what is said not to be, and we know that it is different from the others. Isn’t this so?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

160d

Parmenides: “So we should say from the beginning as follows, what must be the case if one is not. Now, the first thing that must pertain to it is, it seems, that there be knowledge of it, otherwise we would not know what is being said when someone says, ‘if one is not’.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

Parmenides: “Also, must not the others be different from it, otherwise it could not be said to be different from the others?”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

160e

Parmenides: “And so, difference belongs to it in addition to the knowledge. For whenever the one is said to be different from the others, the difference of that one is referred to, and not the difference of the others.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently.”

Parmenides: “And indeed, the one that is not would share in that, in something, and in by-this and in to-this and in these, and in everything of this sort. For the one could not be spoken of, nor could things different from the one, nor could anything be to that or of that, nor could it be referred to as anything if it did not have a share either of something or of these others.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

161a

Parmenides: “In that case, although the one cannot partake of ‘to be’, since it is not, there is nothing to prevent it from partaking of many things and this is actually necessary if indeed that one, and not another, is not. In fact, if neither the one, nor that, are not to be, but the argument concerns something else, then nothing should even be uttered. But if that one and no other is hypothesised not to be, it must also have a share in that, and in many others.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, indeed.”

Parmenides: “So the one also has unlikeness in relation to the others. For things other than the one, being different, would also be different in kind.”

Aristoteles: “Yes”

Parmenides: “And are not things that are different in kind, other in kind?”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

161b

Parmenides: “And things that are other in kind are unlike, are they not?”

Aristoteles: “Yes, unlike.”

Parmenides: “Now, if they are indeed unlike the one, it is obvious that unlike things would be unlike something that is unlike them.”

Aristoteles: “It is obvious.”

Parmenides: “In that case, the one would also have unlikeness in respect of which the others are unlike it.”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

Parmenides: “But if it actually has unlikeness to the others, must it not necessarily have likeness to itself?”

Aristoteles: “In what way?”

Parmenides: “If the one has unlikeness to the one, the argument would not, presumably, be about something of this sort, something like the one, nor would the hypothesis be about one, but about something other than one.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

161c

Parmenides: “But it should not be about that.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “So the one must have likeness of this to itself.”

Aristoteles: “It must.”

Parmenides: “And furthermore, the one is not equal to the others either. For if it were to be equal it would already be, and it would also be like them, based on the equality. But both these

outcomes are impossible if indeed one is not.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, impossible.”

Parmenides: “And since the one is not equal to the others, isn’t it necessary that the others are not equal to the one?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “Are not things that are not equal, unequal?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And unequals are unequal to an unequal, are they not?”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

161d

Parmenides: “And in that case, does the one partake of inequality in respect of which the others are unequal to it?”

Aristoteles: “It partakes.”

Parmenides: “But inequality involves largeness and smallness.”

Aristoteles: “It does.”

Parmenides: “So, does a one of this sort have largeness and smallness?”

Aristoteles: “Quite likely.”

Parmenides: “But largeness and smallness always stand apart from one another.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “So there is always something in between them?”

Aristoteles: “There is.”

Parmenides: “Now, can you say that there is anything in between them except equality?”

Aristoteles: “Nothing except this.”

161e

Parmenides: “So, whatever has largeness and smallness also has an equality which is in between these two.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently.”

Parmenides: “Then the one that is not would, it seems, also have a share of equality as well as largeness and smallness.”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

Parmenides: “And indeed, it should also, in a way, have a share of being.”

Aristoteles: “In what way?”

Parmenides: “It must be such as we describe it, for if it were not such as we describe it, we would not be speaking the truth when we say that the one is not. But if we are speaking the truth, it is obvious that we are stating what actually is. Is this not so?”

Aristoteles: “It is so indeed.”

Parmenides: “And since we maintain that we are speaking the truth, we must also maintain that we are stating what is.”

Aristoteles: “We must.”

162a

Parmenides: “So the one is, it seems, if it is not. For if it were not to be what is not, but were somehow to let go of its being in relation to not being, it would immediately be what is.”

Aristoteles: “Entirely so.”

Parmenides: “So, if it is not to be, it must have being what is not as a bond of not being, in just the same way that what is must have not being what is not, so that it in turn may be in every respect. For in this way, most of all, what is would be, and

what is not would not be, by what is partaking of the being of being what is, and the being of not being what is not, if it is to be in every respect, and on the other hand, by what is not partaking of the being of not being what is, and of the being of being what is not, if it too is in turn not to be in every respect.”

162b

Aristoteles: “Very true.”

Parmenides: “Now, since what is also shares in non-being, and what is not shares in being, the one must necessarily share in being in respect of its non-being, since it is not.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “In fact then, it appears that the one has being, if it is not.”

Aristoteles: “So it appears.”

Parmenides: “And also to have non-being if in fact it is not.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “Now, can something that is in a certain state not be in that state without changing from that state?”

Aristoteles: “It cannot.”

162c

Parmenides: “So everything of this sort, which is both so and not so, implies change.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “And change is motion, or what shall we maintain?”

Aristoteles: “It is motion.”

Parmenides: “Didn’t the one turn out to be and not to be?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And so it appears in this way to be both so and not so.”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

Parmenides: “And so the one that is not turns out to be in motion, since it has turned out to be changing from possessing being to possessing not being.”

Aristoteles: “Quite likely.”

Parmenides: “Then again, if it is not included anywhere among things that are, which it is not since it is not, it would not relocate from one place to another.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

162d

Parmenides: “So it would not move by changing place.”

Aristoteles: “It would not.”

Parmenides: “Nor indeed would it revolve in the same, since it has no contact with the same anywhere. For the same is something that is, and what is not cannot be in any of the things that are.”

Aristoteles: “No, it cannot.”

Parmenides: “So the one that is not would not be able to revolve in that in which it is not.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “Nor could the one, whether it is or is not, be altered from itself. For in that case the argument would no longer be about the one if it were actually altered from itself, but about something else.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

162e

Parmenides: “But if it is not altered, nor does it revolve in the same place, nor does it change place, could it still move in any way?”

Aristoteles: “No, how could it?”

Parmenides: “But that which is not moving must necessarily be still, and that which is still must be at rest.”

Aristoteles: “It must.”

Parmenides: “So the one, it seems, although it is not, is both at rest and in motion.”

Aristoteles: “So it seems.”

163a

Parmenides: “And indeed, if in fact the one is moved, there is a strong necessity that it be altered. For according to the manner in which something is moved, it is to that extent no longer just as it was, but is different.”

Aristoteles: “Quite so.”

Parmenides: “So the one, since it is being moved, is also being altered.”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Then again, since it is not being moved in any way, it would not be altered in any way.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “So, insofar as the one that is not is moved, it is altered, but insofar as it is not moved it is not altered.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “So the one that is not is both altered and not altered.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently.”

163b

Parmenides: “Now, must not that which is altered come to be different than before and cease to be in its former state, while that which is not altered must neither come to be, nor cease to be?”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “And so the one that is not, because it is being altered, is both coming to be and ceasing to be. And because it is not being altered it is neither coming to be nor ceasing to be, and accordingly, the one that is not is both coming to be and ceasing to be, and neither coming to be nor ceasing to be.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed it is not.”

163c

Parmenides: “Then let us go back once again to the beginning and see if different outcomes or the same outcomes will appear to us as appeared just now.”

Aristoteles: “We should do so.”

Parmenides: “In that case, are we to state what the consequences for the one must be, if the one is not?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “Whenever we say ‘is not’, isn’t this simply indicating the absence of being in that which we maintain is not?”

Aristoteles: “Nothing else.”

Parmenides: “Now, whenever we maintain that something is not, are we maintaining that in a way it is not, and in a way it is? Or is the phrase ‘is not’ simply indicating that whatever is not, is not at all in any way, and does not partake of being in any way?”

Aristoteles: “Yes, simply that.”

163d

Parmenides: “So, what is not could not be, nor could it partake of being in any other way at all.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “But coming to be and ceasing to be are nothing but the acquisition of being and the loss of being.”

Aristoteles: “Nothing but.”

Parmenides: “But that which has no share of being could neither have acquired it nor lost it.”

Aristoteles: “No, how could it?”

Parmenides: “So, since the one is not in any way, it could not possess or lose or acquire being in any way at all.”

Aristoteles: “Quite likely.”

Parmenides: “So the one that is not neither ceases to be, nor comes to be, since in fact it does not partake of being in any way.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently not.”

163e

Parmenides: “So the one that is not is not altered in any way, for if this happened it would already be both coming into being and ceasing to be.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

Parmenides: “But if it is not altered, then necessarily it is not moved either.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “Nor indeed shall we maintain that what in no way is, is at rest. For that which is at rest must always be in something the same.”

Aristoteles: “In the same, yes of course.”

Parmenides: “Accordingly, we should also say that what is not is never either at rest or in motion.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed it is not.”

164a

Parmenides: “But in that case, none of the things that are belong to it, for it would then partake of being by partaking of this.”

Aristoteles: “Obviously.”

Parmenides: “So neither largeness nor smallness nor equality belong to it.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “Nor would likeness or difference belong to it, neither with respect to itself, nor with respect to the others.”

Aristoteles: “Apparently not.”

Parmenides: “What about this? If it can have nothing, is there any way that it can have others?”

Aristoteles: “There is not.”

Parmenides: “So the others are neither like nor unlike, nor the same as it nor different from it.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

164b

Parmenides: “What about this? Will there be of that, or to that, or something, or this, or of this, or of another, or to another, or once, or was, or now, or knowledge, or opinion, or perception, or an account, or a name, or will any of the other things that are be related to what is not?”

Aristoteles: “They will not.”

Parmenides: “Accordingly then, the one, if it is not, is not characterised in any way at all.”

Aristoteles: “Well, it certainly seems not.”

Parmenides: “In that case we should go on to say how the others must be characterised if one is not.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, we should.”

Parmenides: “Now, they must somehow be others, for if they are not even others we would not be talking about the others.”

Aristoteles: “Quite so.”

Parmenides: “But if the argument is about the others, the others are different, or don’t you refer to the same thing as both other and different?”

164c

Aristoteles: “I do.”

Parmenides: “And we maintain, I presume, that what is different is different from something different, and what is other is other than something other?”

Aristoteles: “Yes.”

Parmenides: “And the others, if they are to be others, will have something to be other than.”

Aristoteles: “Necessarily.”

Parmenides: “Now, what would that actually be? Indeed, they will not be other than the one since the one is not.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “So they are other than one another. Indeed this option still remains for them, or alternatively, to be other than nothing.”

Aristoteles: “Correct.”

164d

Parmenides: “So they are other than one another, in each case, as multiplicities, for they could not be so as ones, since one is not. But in each case, it seems, the mass of them is unlimited in multiplicity, and if someone takes what seems to be the smallest part, suddenly, just as in a dream while sleeping, it appears to be many instead of seeming to be one, and instead of seeming miniscule, it appears enormous in comparison with any parts that are cut from it.”

Aristoteles: “Quite right.”

Parmenides: “In which case, the others would be other than each other as masses of this sort if the others are, although one is not.”

Aristoteles: “Precisely.”

Parmenides: “Won’t there be many masses, each appearing to be one without being so, if in fact one is not to be?”

Aristoteles: “Quite so.”

164e

Parmenides: “And if in fact each seems to be one, there will seem to be a number of them since they are many.”

Aristoteles: “Certainly.”

Parmenides: “And some among them appear to be even, others odd, without in truth being so, if in fact one is not to be.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed.”

165a

Parmenides: “And furthermore, according to us, a smallest will seem to be among them, but this appears to be many and large, relative to each of the many because they are small.”

Aristoteles: “Of course.”

Parmenides: “And each mass will be imagined to be equal to what is many and small, for it could not give the appearance of

changing from greater to lesser before seeming to arrive at whatever is in between, and this would be apparent equality.”

Aristoteles: “Quite likely.”

Parmenides: “Would it not have limit relative to another mass, while having, itself, neither a beginning limit, nor middle, relative to itself?”

Aristoteles: “Why is that?”

165b

Parmenides: “Because whenever anyone, in thought, grasps any of these as if it were one of them, then another beginning always appears before that beginning, and after the end, another end still remains, and in the middle others more in the middle, but smaller due to the impossibility of grasping each of them as one, since one is not.”

Aristoteles: “Very true.”

Parmenides: “So it must be the case, I believe, for anything that is, that whatever one grasps in thought, even as it is being cut into pieces, must crumble apart. For it would always be grasped, somehow, as a mass devoid of the one.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, certainly.”

165c

Parmenides: “Now, isn’t it necessary that something of this sort must appear to be one to anyone who views it dimly from afar, while to someone who considers it keenly from close up, each one must appear unlimited in multiplicity if it is actually deprived of the one because the one is not?”

Aristoteles: “Yes, absolutely necessary.”

Parmenides: “In that case then, the others must each appear limitless and possessed of limit, and one and many, if one is not and there are things other than one.”

Aristoteles: “They must indeed.”

Parmenides: “Won’t they also seem to be both like and unlike?”

Aristoteles: “In what way?”

Parmenides: “In the way that shadow drawings all appear one to a person standing away from them, and appear to have a characteristic the same, and to be like.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed.”

165d

Parmenides: “But to someone who has approached them they appear many and different, and by the appearance of difference they appear to be different in character and unlike themselves.”

Aristoteles: “So they do.”

Parmenides: “And so the masses themselves necessarily appear like and unlike themselves and one another.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, certainly.”

165e

Parmenides: “Therefore if one is not, and there are many, these must appear both the same as and different from one another, both in contact with and apart from themselves, both moving with every motion and at rest in every respect, both coming to be and ceasing to be and neither, and everything else of this sort, I presume, which we could easily set out at this stage.”

Aristoteles: “Very true.”

Parmenides: “Then let us go back once again to the beginning, and let us say what must be the case if one is not and there are things other than one.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, let us do so.”

Parmenides: “In that case, the others will not be one.”

Aristoteles: “No, how could they?”

Parmenides: “Nor indeed will they be many since one would then be present in things that are many. For if no one of them is one, they are all nothing, and so they could not be many.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

Parmenides: “But without the one being present in the others, the others are neither many nor one.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

166a

Parmenides: “Nor do they even appear to be one or many.”

Aristoteles: “Why is that?”

Parmenides: “Because the others do not have any communion whatsoever in any way at all with any of the things that are not, nor does anything from the others belong to things that are not, since there is no part of things that are not.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

Parmenides: “Nor is there any opinion of what is not, with the others, nor any appearance either, nor is what is not thought of in any way at all by the others.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

166b

Parmenides: “So if one is not, none of the others is thought to be either one or many, for it is impossible to think of many in the absence of one.”

Aristoteles: “Yes, impossible.”

Parmenides: “So if one is not, the others neither are, nor are thought to be, one or many.”

Aristoteles: “It seems not.”

Parmenides: “Nor are they like, nor are they unlike.”

Aristoteles: “Indeed not.”

Parmenides: “Nor are they the same, nor different, nor in contact, nor separate, nor are they anything else that they appeared to be in our earlier description. They neither are, nor appear to be, any of these if one is not.”

Aristoteles: “True.”

166c

Parmenides: “In that case, if we were to maintain, in short, that if one is not then nothing is, would we be right to say so?”

Aristoteles: “Entirely so.”

Parmenides: “So, let us say this, and also that, as it seems, whether one is or is not, both itself and the others, in relation to themselves and to one another, both are and are not, and appear and do not appear to be all things in all ways.”

Aristoteles: “Very true.”

NOTES

1. Adimantus and Glaucon were Plato's older brothers. They are the main interlocutors with Socrates in Plato's Republic.
2. Zeno of Elea was a philosopher and student of Parmenides who became famous for his paradoxes.
3. Parmenides of Elea was a famous philosopher and founder of the Eleatic school of philosophy.
4. The Panathenaea was an annual festival held over several days in Athens in honour of the goddess Athena. Every four years it was celebrated as the Great Panathenaea.
5. This phrase could be rendered as 'the many are not', 'there is no multiplicity', or as 'multiplicity does not exist'.
6. The Greek phrase here is *ei polla esti*. We have rendered it as 'if many are', but it could be translated as 'if [things] are many'.
7. Ibycus of Rhegium was a lyric poet who was noted, in particular, for his verses on love.
8. Some scholars justify translating this phrase as 'if one is or if it is not'.
9. The phrase 'if one is' can also be translated as 'if it [the one or the all?] is one'. This, however, would make the first hypothesis predicative, while all of the others are existential.

Phaedo

ΦΑΙΔΩΝ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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narrator: PHAEDO of Elis, a student of Socrates, founder of philosophy school
persons in the dialogue:

ECHECRATES *of Phlius, a student of Philolaus and Eurytus*

SOCRATES *of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus*

WARDER *a prison attendant*

XANTHIPPE *Socrates' wife*

CRITO *a friend and contemporary of Socrates*

SIMMIAS *Theban, Pythagorean*

CEBES *Theban, Pythagorean*

POISONER *a public slave*

scene: a meeting of Phaedo and Echecrates in Phlius, a month after Socrates' death / Socrates' prison cell

57a

Echecrates: Were you yourself there with Socrates on the day he drank the poison in the prison, Phaedo,¹ or did you hear about it from someone else?

Phaedo: I was there myself, Echecrates.²

Echecrates: Well then, what did the man say before his death? And how did he die? I would love to hear about this. The fact is, no one from Phlius tends to visit Athens much these days, nor has any visitor come from there for quite a while, someone who could give us a definite account of those events, apart from saying that he drank the poison and died. They had nothing to say about anything else.

57b

Phaedo: So did you not even find out the details of the way the trial unfolded?

58a

Echecrates: Yes, someone did report these events to us, and we were surprised that although the trial took place some time ago, he was evidently put to death much more recently. Why did

that happen, Phaedo?

Phaedo: In his case, it was the result of a coincidence, Echecrates. It so happened that the prow of the ship which the Athenians send to Delos was crowned the day before the trial.

58b

Echecrates: And what ship is this?

Phaedo: It is the ship on which, according to the Athenians, Theseus once travelled to Crete bringing the “twice seven” young people, and he saved them and saved himself.³ Now, it is said that they vowed to Apollo, there and then, to send a sacred expedition to Delos every year if they were saved. Accordingly, every year since then, including this year, they send an expedition to honour the god. Now, they have a law that once they begin the expedition, the city is to be kept pure during that period, and no one may be executed by the authorities until the ship has arrived at Delos and returned once more, and on occasion, whenever the winds happen to detain them, this takes a lot of time. The sacred expedition begins once the priest of Apollo crowns the prow of the ship, and this happened, as I said, the day before the trial took place. That is why Socrates had so much time in prison between the trial and his death.

58c

Echecrates: Yes, but what about the circumstances of the actual death, Phaedo? What did people say and how did they behave? Which of his friends were present with him? Or did the authorities not allow them to be there, and did he die bereft of friends?

Phaedo: Not at all. A number of them were present, quite a number, in fact.

Echecrates: Then try to recount all the details to us as clearly as possible, provided you have the time.

58d

Phaedo: Well, I do have the time and I shall try to give you an account. Yes, indeed, being reminded of Socrates is always the greatest delight of all to me, whether I speak of him myself or hear about him from someone else.

Echecrates: In that case, Phaedo, you have listeners who are like-minded, so try to recount everything as precisely as you can.

Phaedo: Well, I myself had a strange feeling while I was there, for I did not experience the usual pity of someone present at the death of a friend. Indeed, he himself appeared happy to me, Echecrates, both in his manner and in his words, so fearlessly and nobly did he meet his end. I was convinced he was not going to Hades without a divine portion and, indeed, that he would fare well even when he arrived there, if anyone ever does. These are the reasons I did not feel much of the pity which would seem to be expected of someone on a sad occasion. Nor again, did I feel the pleasure which is usual when we are engaged in philosophy, and our discussions were indeed of that kind. Instead, I had an utterly unusual feeling – a strange mixture combining pleasure and a like measure of pain – at the realisation that Socrates was going to pass away soon. And all those present were in much the same state, laughing at one moment and crying at the next, Apollodorus more than any of us. I presume you know the man and his character.

58e

Echecrates: I do, of course.

Phaedo: Well, he was completely overcome, and I was troubled myself, as were the others.

Echecrates: Who else was present, Phaedo?

59b

Phaedo: Of native Athenians, Apollodorus himself was present, and also Critobulus and his father, along with Hermogenes,

Epigenes, Aeschines and Antisthenes. And there was Ctesippus the Paeanian, Menexenus, and some other Athenians.⁴ Plato, I believe, was ill.

Echecrates: Were there any visitors present?

Phaedo: Yes, Simmias of Thebes, Cebes and Phaidondes. And from Megara there was Euclides and Terpsion.⁵

59c

Echecrates: What about Cleombrotus and Aristippus?⁶ Were they there?

Phaedo: Actually, they were not. In fact, they were said to have been on Aegina.

59d

Echecrates: And was anyone else there?

Phaedo: I think that is just about everyone who was present.

Echecrates: In that case, will you tell us what discussions took place?

Phaedo: I shall try to recount everything to you from the beginning.

Now, I myself and the others had always been in the habit of going to visit Socrates on the previous days, gathering at daybreak at the court where the trial took place, for this was near the prison. Every day we used to wait and converse with one another until the prison was opened, as it did not open early, and once it was opened, we would go in to Socrates and spend most of the day with him. We actually met earlier that morning because on the previous day, after we left the prison in the evening, we found out that the ship had returned from Delos, so we encouraged one another to get to our usual meeting place as early as possible next morning.

59e

When we arrived, the doorkeeper came out as usual to answer us, and he told us to wait and not to go in until he called us.

Warder: “The Eleven⁷ are unchaining Socrates, and are giving instructions about how he is to die today.”

Now, it did not take him long before he returned and bade us enter. In we went and took in the scene: Socrates, just released from his bonds, and Xanthippe,⁸ I am sure you know her, sitting beside him holding his little child. Once Xanthippe saw us, she cried out and said the sort of thing women usually say,

60a

Xanthippe: “O Socrates, your friends will be speaking to you now for the very last time, and you to them.”

Then Socrates glanced towards Crito and said,

Socrates: “Have someone take her home, Crito.”

And some of Crito’s people led her away, crying and beating her breast, while Socrates sat up in the bed, bent his leg, rubbed it with his hand, and said as he was rubbing it,

60b

Socrates: “Gentlemen, this thing which people call pleasure seems to be so strange. It is so extraordinarily related to pain, though this appears to be its opposite, for the two tend not to come to a person at the same time. Yet if someone pursues one and obtains it, he is almost always compelled to take the other, as though the two were joined to a single head. And it seems to me that if Aesop⁹ had thought about this, he would have made up a fable that the god wished to reconcile their strife, but as he was unable to do so he fastened their heads together, and that is why when one arises in someone the other also follows after it. It seems that is what just happened to me. After the pain in my leg on account of the chain, the pleasure now appears to follow.”

60c

Cebes: Then Cebes took this up and said, “By Zeus, it is just as well you jogged my memory, Socrates. A number of people have been asking me about your compositions, the setting of Aesop’s fables to verse and the hymn to Apollo. In fact, Evenus¹⁰ also asked me recently what exactly you had in mind, since you composed these works on arriving in prison, even though you had not composed anything before then. Now, if you would like me to have an answer for Evenus, tell me what I should say whenever he asks me again, for I know very well that he will ask.”

60d

Socrates: “Tell him the truth, Cebes,” he replied. “I did not compose these works with a view to rivalling him or his poems. No, I knew that would not be easy. Rather, I was testing out the meaning of certain dreams and clearing my conscience in case they were, perhaps, instructing me to make music in the usual sense. Now, the dreams went something like this... the same one often came to me during the course of my life, sometimes in one guise, sometimes in another, but always saying the same thing. ‘Socrates,’ it said, ‘make music and work at it.’ On previous occasions, I assumed it was encouraging and exhorting me to do what I was already doing, just as people call upon runners to run. So I thought the dream was exhorting me to do what I was already doing – namely, to make music – since philosophy is the greatest music, and I was already engaged in that. But once the trial was over and the festival of the god was preventing my execution, it seemed important not to ignore the dream but to act upon it in case it might, perhaps, be instructing me to make music in the popular sense of the word. Indeed, it seemed safer not to depart until I had cleared my conscience by composing these works in obedience to the dream. So I first composed something for the god whose festival season it was, and after that I realised that a poet needs to compose stories rather than factual accounts if he is actually going to be a poet, and that I

myself was no storyteller. So I took whatever stories were to hand, the fables of Aesop which I know, and turned the first ones I came upon into verse. So Cebes, tell this to Evenus and bid him farewell, and bid him pursue me as quickly as possible if he is of sound mind. I am departing today, it seems, for the people of Athens have given their command.”

60e

Simmias: And Simmias said, “What an instruction to give to Evenus, Socrates! I have met the man many times already, and from what I know of him he will never be persuaded by your request, not willingly anyway.”

Socrates: “Why not?” he replied. “Is Evenus not a philosopher?”

Simmias: “Well, I think he is,” said Simmias.

61c

Socrates: “Then Evenus will indeed be willing, and so will anyone who engages in this activity in a worthy manner. However, he will not do violence to himself, for this, they say, is not lawful.”

And as he was saying this, he placed his feet on the ground and then conducted the rest of the discussion seated in that manner. So Cebes asked him,

Cebes: “Socrates, what do you mean by ‘it is not lawful to do violence to himself’ and that a philosopher should be willing to follow someone who is dying?”

Socrates: “What is this, Cebes? Have you and Simmias not heard about such matters through your association with Philolaus?”¹¹

Cebes: “Not in any detail, Socrates.”

61d

Socrates: “Well, I too am recounting what I have heard about these issues. However, I will not begrudge you an account of whatever I happen to have heard. For it is perhaps especially appropriate for someone about to depart to the next world to consider the sojourn there and tell stories about what we think it will be like. Indeed, what else could one do until the time when the sun sets?”

61e

Cebes: “Socrates, on what precise basis is it said not to be lawful for someone to kill themselves? I have also heard Philolaus saying what you have just said when he was living among us, and I have heard from a number of others since that one should not do this. But I have never yet heard anything clear concerning these issues from anyone.”

62a

Socrates: “Then you should bestir yourself,” he said, “for perhaps then you will actually hear. However, it may perhaps seem surprising to you that this situation alone, in contrast to all others, admits of no exceptions and is never like other personal circumstances. Sometimes, for some people, it is better to be dead than to be alive. But if they are better off dead, perhaps it seems surprising to you that it is unholy for those very people themselves to act beneficially towards themselves, rather than waiting for another to perform that service.”

And Cebes smiled gently and exclaimed in his own dialect,

Cebes: “Zeus be my witness!”

62b

Socrates: “Yes, indeed,” said Socrates, “it may sound illogical when expressed in that way. However, in spite of that, perhaps it does make some sense. The account about these matters, uttered in secret, declares that we humans are under guardianship and people should not free themselves from it or run away. This seems important to me, though it is not easy to

understand. In any case, Cebes, I do think this is well expressed. The gods are our guardians and we humans are among the possessions of the gods. Do you not think so too?"

Cebes: "I do, indeed," said Cebes.

62c

Socrates: "Well, then," said he, "if one of your own possessions were to kill itself, with no indication from you that you wanted it dead, would you not be angry with it? And would you not punish it if you could do so?"

Cebes: "Very much so," he replied.

Socrates: "Perhaps then, in this sense, it is not illogical to say that someone should not kill themselves until a god sends some necessity, such as my present predicament."

62d

Cebes: "Well," said Cebes, "that appears reasonable anyway. However, when you said just now that the wish to die comes readily to philosophers, that, dear Socrates, sounded strange, especially if what we were saying just now is reasonable, that the god is our guardian and we are his possessions. For it does not make sense for the wisest folk to be untroubled on departing from this care in which the gods, the very best guardians of beings, watch over them. For I presume they will not believe that they will take better care of themselves once they are free. Now, an unreasonable person might think that he should flee from his master, and he would not figure out that one should not flee from the good but should stay as long as possible, and so he might make an unreasonable escape. However, the reasonable person would presumably desire to be constantly in the presence of someone better than himself. So on this basis, Socrates, the situation is likely to be the opposite of what you just said: it is appropriate for the wise to be troubled at the prospect of death and for the foolish to rejoice."

63a

Now, I thought Socrates was pleased with Cebes' analysis, and he looked at us and said,

Socrates: "Cebes is always scrutinising some argument or other and is not very willing to be persuaded as soon as someone makes any assertion."

Simmias: Then Simmias said, "Well, on this occasion anyway, I believe that Cebes has a point. For why would people who are truly wise wish to flee from masters who are better than themselves, and take their leave of them so readily? And Cebes seems to be directing his argument at you because you are going so readily, leaving us and those good rulers whom, you agree, are gods."

63b

Socrates: "What you are saying is fair," he replied, "for I think you mean that I must defend myself against these charges as if I were in a court of law."

Simmias: "Yes, very much so," said Simmias.

Socrates: "Come on, then," he said, "and I shall try to conduct my defence more persuasively in front of you than I did in front of the jurors. Indeed, Simmias and Cebes, if I did not believe, firstly, that I would be going to various wise and good gods, and secondly, to men who have died, better men than those who are here, I would be wrong to be untroubled by death.

63c

Socrates: "Now, although I am hoping to arrive among good men, please note that I would not assert this very confidently. However, rest assured that if I were to assert anything else of this sort with confidence, I would also say that I am going to gods who are perfectly good masters. So on this basis I am not so troubled by all this, but am quite hopeful that there is something for those who have died, and, as the ancient saying

puts it, 'at least it is much better for those who are good than for those who are bad'."

63d

Simmias: "What now, Socrates?" said Simmias. "Do you intend to depart keeping this understanding to yourself or would you be prepared to share it with us? For it seems to me that this is something good to be shared with us too, and at the same time it will act as your defence if you persuade us of what you are saying."

Socrates: "In that case, I shall try," he said. "But first, I think Crito here wanted to speak a while ago. Let's ask him what he wants."

Crito: "Socrates," said Crito, "it is just that the man who is going to give you the poison has been saying to me for some time that you should be told to converse as little as possible, for he says that people who converse become more heated, and this sort of thing should be avoided before the poison is to be administered. Otherwise, people who do this are sometimes compelled to drink the poison twice or even three times."

63e

Socrates: And Socrates replied, "Do not mind him; just let him attend to his own duty and give the poison twice, and, if necessary, three times."

Crito: "Yes, I was quite sure you would say that," said Crito, "but he has been bothering me about these things for some time."

Socrates: "Let him be," Socrates replied. "And instead, I now want to present an argument to you jurors as to why it seems likely to me that a man who has really spent his life in philosophy is confident when facing death, and is hopeful that he will obtain enormous benefits in the next world once he dies. Of course, Simmias and Cebes, I shall now try to explain how

this might be the case. For most people are likely to be unaware that those who engage properly in philosophy are themselves in pursuit of nothing except dying and being dead. Now, if this is true, it would surely be strange for someone who was eager all his life for this alone to be troubled when he actually attained what he had pursued so eagerly for so long.”

64a

Then Simmias laughed and said,

Simmias: “By Zeus, Socrates, I am not really in laughing humour just now, but you have made me laugh. Yes, I believe that most people, on hearing this, would think you have made a very good point about philosophers, and our own people would agree emphatically that those who engage in philosophy really do have a longing for death, and that this is the fate they deserve to suffer! They are quite aware of that.”

64b

Socrates: “And in a sense, Simmias, what they are saying would be true, except for their claim that they are aware. For they are unaware of the way in which true philosophers desire death, or the sense in which they deserve to die, or what kind of death it is. Indeed, we should just speak among ourselves”, he said, “and bid farewell to those fellows. Do we think that death is something?”

Simmias: “Very much so,” replied Simmias.

Socrates: “Is it anything other than the separation of the soul from the body? And is this what it is to be dead? The body is separated from the soul and is just by itself, while the soul, having been separated from the body, is just by itself? Is death anything other than this?”

Simmias: “It is nothing but this,” he replied.

64c

Socrates: “Now, good man, consider whether your views are the same as mine. Indeed, from these, I believe we shall come to know more about the issues we are investigating. Does it appear to you that a person who loves wisdom would be serious about such so-called pleasures as eating and drinking?”

64d

Simmias: “Not in the least, Socrates,” replied Simmias.

Socrates: “What about sexual pleasures?”

Simmias: “Not at all.”

Socrates: “And what about the other indulgences associated with the body? Do you think people of this sort would regard them as valuable? I mean, would they value the acquisition of distinctive clothing or shoes and other adornments of the body, or do you think they would disregard them and partake of them only to the extent really necessary?”

64e

Simmias: “I think the true philosopher would disregard them.”

Socrates: “Don’t you think,” he said, “in general, that the preoccupation of such a person is not about the body, but is directed away from it as much as possible, and turned towards the soul?”

Simmias: “I do indeed.”

65a

Socrates: “So is it obvious, in the first place, that in such matters the philosopher exceeds all others in freeing the soul, as much as possible, from communion with the body?”

Simmias: “So it appears.”

Socrates: “And it seems to most people, I presume, Simmias, that someone to whom nothing of this sort is pleasant, and who does not partake thereof, does not deserve to be alive, and that a person who thinks nothing of the pleasures which derive from

the body is well-nigh dead.”

Simmias: “Yes, what you are saying is certainly true.”

65b

Socrates: “But what about the acquisition of wisdom itself? Is the body an impediment or not if it is brought along to assist in the search? My question goes something like this: do sight and hearing afford men any truth? Or is there truth in the sort of things even the poets are constantly repeating to us, that we neither see nor hear anything accurately? And, indeed, if these two bodily senses are neither accurate nor clear, it would be idle to consider the others, for they are all somehow inferior to these two, or doesn’t it seem so to you?”

Simmias: “It does seem so to me.”

65c

Socrates: “So when does the soul encounter the truth? For whenever it attempts to contemplate anything in conjunction with the body, in that case it is obviously deceived by the body.”

Simmias: “What you say is true.”

Socrates: “Well, isn’t it in reasoning rather than anywhere else that any of the things that are, become obvious to it?”

Simmias: “Yes.”

Socrates: “But presumably, then, the soul reasons most beautifully whenever nothing else bothers it, neither hearing nor sight nor pain nor any pleasure, and it is just by itself to the greatest extent possible, bids the body farewell, has as little communion and contact with it as it can, and reaches towards what is.”

Simmias: “This is so.”

65d

Socrates: “Then, is it here too that the soul of the philosopher shows most disregard for the body, flees from it, and strives to

be just by itself?”

Simmias: “So it appears.”

Socrates: “But Simmias, what about this? Do we say that there is something just itself, or nothing is?”

Simmias: “By Zeus, we do indeed say that there is.”

Socrates: “And something is beautiful and is itself good?”

Simmias: “How could there not be?”

Socrates: “Now, have you ever yet seen anything of this kind with your eyes?”

Simmias: “Not at all.”

Socrates: “But have you ever contacted them through the body by means of any other sense? And I am referring to all of them, for example, size, health, strength and all the others. In short, I am speaking of the being of them all, what each of them happens to be. Can the very truth of them be contemplated by means of the body? Or is it the case that whoever is best and most diligently prepared to understand each of these, in itself, is the person who will come closest to the knowledge of them?”

Simmias: “Yes, certainly.”

65e

Socrates: “Now, wouldn’t a person undertake this with the utmost purity if he were to make his approach to each of them with the mind alone to the greatest possible extent? Without introducing sight into the mental activity, or dragging in any other sense perception whatsoever along with the reasoning, but making use of the mind just by itself, without admixture, wouldn’t he take up the hunt for each of the things that are, as free as possible from eyes and ears and, in effect, from all that is bodily, for this disturbs the soul and does not allow it to acquire truth and wisdom whenever it communes with the body? Won’t

this person, Simmias, and no other, attain what is?”

66a

Simmias: “Socrates, what you are saying is extraordinarily true,” replied Simmias.

Socrates: “Then,” he said, “the genuine philosophers must form a particular opinion based upon these conclusions so that they say something of this sort to one another: ‘Yes, a sort of narrow path seems to be leading us on to side with reason in the enquiry, because as long as we have the body, and our soul is compounded with such badness, we shall never satisfactorily obtain what we desire, and this we say is the truth. Indeed, the body brings countless distractions upon us just because it needs sustenance. What is more, if any illnesses befall it, they impede our hunt for what is. And the body also fills us with loves, desires, fears, a whole range of imaginings, and a lot of foolishness, so that, as they say, and it really is true, we never ever acquire any wisdom at all through its agency. And in fact, it is only the body and its desires which bring about wars, insurrections and fighting. For all wars arise on account of the possession of wealth, and we are compelled to acquire wealth because of the body, as we are slaves in its service. And because of all these factors, we become too busy to engage in philosophy. Worst of all, even if we do get time, free from its demands, and turn towards some philosophic enquiry, the body keeps intruding into the enquiry in all sorts of ways, bringing tribulation and agitation, and confounding us so that we are unable to see truth clearly because of it. But, in fact, this argument has shown us that if we are ever going to have pure knowledge of anything, we must be quit of the body and behold the objects themselves, with the soul itself. We claim to be lovers of wisdom, and we shall obtain what we desire and what we claim to love, when we die, as the argument indicates, but not while we are alive.

66e

Socrates: “Indeed, if it is impossible to know anything purely whilst accompanied by the body, there are two possibilities. Either it is impossible to acquire the knowledge at all, or it happens after death, for then, and not until then, will the soul be just by itself, separate from the body. And while we are living in the body, in this way we shall, it seems, be closest to acquiring knowledge when we have the least interaction and communion with it, only what is absolutely necessary and are not contaminated with its nature, but purify ourselves from it, until God himself releases us. And in this way, being pure and liberated from the foolishness of the body, we are likely to be with those who are like this, and we shall know all that is pure through ourselves alone. And this, I daresay, is the truth: that the impure has no contact with the pure for that would not be lawful.’ I believe, Simmias, that this is the sort of thing which all those with a proper love of learning will think and say to each other. Is that how it seems to you?”

67b

Simmias: “More than anything, Socrates.”

Socrates: “Therefore,” said Socrates, “if this is all true, my friend, there is great hope that when someone arrives where I am going, there, if anywhere, they fully attain that objective which has given rise to so much endeavour in our lives so far. So this departure which is now forced upon me offers good hope for any man who believes he has prepared his mind, which has, in a sense, been purified.”

Simmias: “Yes, certainly,” said Simmias.

67c

Socrates: “But does not this purification turn out to be just what we said it was in the earlier discussion: the separation of soul from body to the greatest extent possible; getting soul accustomed to gathering itself together, and collecting itself

from all parts of the body, to dwell just by itself as best it can, both in its present situation and hereafter; being set free from the body as though from bonds?”

67d

Simmias: “Yes, certainly.”

Socrates: “And isn’t this how death is described, a freeing and separation of soul from body?”

Simmias: “Entirely so.”

Socrates: “And we are saying that it is only those who engage in philosophy correctly who are always most eager to free the soul. This is the particular practice of the philosophers; the freeing and separating of soul from body. Is this so?”

Simmias: “So it appears.”

67e

Socrates: “So, as I said in the beginning, it would be ridiculous for a man who prepares himself throughout life by being as close to death as possible, and who lives accordingly, to be troubled at the arrival of his own death.”

Simmias: “Ridiculous, of course.”

Socrates: “So, in fact, Simmias,” he said, “those who engage properly in philosophy practise dying and, of all people, death is least fearful to them. Reflect upon this. If they are indeed at variance with the body in every way, and they wish to have soul just by itself, but they are fearful and troubled when this happens, wouldn’t that be very irrational? Shouldn’t they be glad to go to a place where there is hope that those who arrive there, freed from association with their former adversary, will attain that which they have loved throughout their lives, and what they have loved is wisdom? When humans’ loved ones, wives or sons, have died, many people have been prepared to go after them willingly into Hades, led by the hope of seeing their

loved ones, and of being with them there. So, if someone actually loves wisdom and has a firm hold of this same hope that he will attain no wisdom worth mentioning anywhere else but in Hades, will he be troubled when he is dying? Won't he be glad to go there? Surely he must think so, my friend, if he is in fact a philosopher, for he will hold strongly to the view that there, and nowhere else, will he attain wisdom in its purity. And if this is the case, then as we said before, it would be highly irrational for such a person to fear death."

68b

Simmias: "Very much so, by Zeus."

Socrates: "Therefore, do you have sufficient evidence", said Socrates, "that a man whom you see grieving when he is going to die is no lover of wisdom, but a lover of the body? The same person also turns out to be a money-lover, or a lover of honour, one or the other or both."

68c

Simmias: "Indeed," he said, "the situation is just as you describe."

Socrates: "Well, Simmias, doesn't what we refer to as courage belong mainly to those with a philosophic disposition?"

Simmias: "Entirely so."

Socrates: "And sound-mindedness too, sound-mindedness as most people describe it, not being aroused in the face of desires but being frugal and orderly. Doesn't this belong only to those who show least regard for the body and spend their lives in philosophy?"

Simmias: "It must."

68d

Socrates: "Now, if you wish to consider the courage and sound-mindedness of other people, it will seem unusual to you."

Simmias: “In what way, Socrates?”

Socrates: “You know that everyone else regards death as one of the great evils?”

Simmias: “Very much so.”

Socrates: “And don’t the courageous among them submit to death, whenever they do so, from fear of greater evils?”

Simmias: “That is what happens.”

Socrates: “So apart from the philosophers, everyone is courageous due to fear and terror. However, it is quite illogical to be courageous due to terror and cowardice.”

Simmias: “It certainly is.”

68e

Socrates: “And what about those among them who are orderly? Aren’t they in the same predicament, namely that they are sound-minded due to a certain lack of restraint? Indeed, we say that this is impossible, but nevertheless this is what their foolish sound-mindedness turns out to be like. They are afraid of being deprived of certain pleasures, so, out of desire for these pleasures, they refrain from other pleasures because they are controlled by these pleasures. However, being ruled by pleasure is what they call lack of restraint, but it now turns out that they control pleasures because they themselves are controlled by other pleasures. This is like what was just referred to: they are, in a way, sound-minded due to lack of restraint.”

Simmias: “So it seems.”

69a

Socrates: “Bless you, Simmias, I suspect that when it comes to excellence, this trading is not right, exchanging pleasures for pleasures, pains for pains, fear for fear and greater for less as if they were coins. No, there is only one proper coin for which all these must be exchanged, and that is wisdom, and everything

should really be bought and sold for this and in conjunction with this. And courage, sound-mindedness, justice and in short, true excellence, should accompany wisdom, whether pleasures, fears and everything else of that sort be present or absent. But if these are exchanged for one another unaccompanied by wisdom, won't such excellence be a shadowy image, which is actually slavish and devoid of anything sound or true? But the true is, in fact, a purification from everything of that sort, and sound-mindedness, justice, courage, and wisdom itself are purifications. And it seems that those who established our mysteries¹² were no ordinary folk, but in fact they said long ago, in riddling language, that whoever arrived in Hades uninitiated and imperfect will lie in the mire, while someone who has been purified and perfected when he arrives there will dwell with the gods. For as they say in the mysteries, ^{69c} The thyrsus bearers are many But the Bacchae are few.¹³

^{69d}

Socrates: “And the Bacchae are, in my view, none other than those who have properly engaged in philosophy. And so, throughout my life, unstintingly and to the best of my ability, I have been eager in every way to become one of them. But whether I have been eager in the right way and whether we have achieved anything, that I shall know for certain quite soon when I arrive there, if it be god's will. That is how it seems to me.

Socrates: “Now, Simmias and Cebes,” said he, “thus do I make my case that it is reasonable to bear without difficulty or tribulation my departure from yourselves and the rulers of this place, for I believe that I shall encounter rulers there who are just as good as these, and companions too. So, if I am any more persuasive towards you with this defence than I was to the Athenian jurors, all would be well.”

^{69e}

Once Socrates had said all this, Cebes responded by saying,

Cebes: “Socrates, it seems to me at least, that in general what you have said is excellent, but what you said about the soul brings up a lot of doubt in people lest it may no longer be anywhere, once it is quit of the body. They believe that it is destroyed and perishes on the very day a person dies, as soon as it is separated from the body, and going forth, dispersed like breath or smoke, it takes flight, is gone and is no longer anywhere at all. However, if the soul were, in fact, just by itself, gathered together, freed from those evils you described just now, there would be a great and beautiful hope, Socrates, that what you are saying is true. But it will probably require no small amount of gentle persuasion to prove that after the person dies the soul exists and possesses some power and wisdom.”

70b

Socrates: “What you say is true, Cebes,” said Socrates. “But what are we to do? Would you like us to converse about this very topic, on the question of whether this is likely to be the case or not?”

Cebes: “I, for my part, would be glad to hear what opinion you hold on these issues,” replied Cebes.

70c

Socrates: “Well,” said Socrates, “I do not think anyone who heard us now, even if he were a comic poet, would say that I am being verbose and I am constructing arguments which are of no relevance. So if you see fit, we should examine the matter in detail.

Socrates: “Let us consider whether the souls of people who have died are in Hades or not, in the following manner. There is an ancient story, which we remember, that the souls exist in the other world having arrived there from this world, and they arrive back here again, coming into being from those who have

died. Now, if this is the case, that the living come into being from those who have died, must not our souls be there, for they could not come into being again if they were not there? And if it actually becomes evident that the living come into being from nothing else than from those who have died, this constitutes an adequate proof that these things are so. But if this is not the case, another argument would be required.”

70d

Cebes: “Yes, certainly,” said Cebes.

70e

Socrates: “Then, if you wish to understand this more easily, do not consider human beings alone, but all animals and plants and, in short, anything which comes to be. Let us see whether any of them which happen to have an opposite comes into being from those opposites. Beauty is presumably opposite to ugliness, just is opposite to unjust, and there are thousands more examples. So let us consider this: whether anything which has an opposite must come into being from nothing else but its own opposite. For instance, whenever something becomes greater, presumably it must have been lesser before and became greater afterwards.”

Cebes: “Yes.”

71a

Socrates: “And if it becomes lesser, does it not become lesser having previously been greater?”

Cebes: “That is so.”

Socrates: “And indeed, from the stronger comes the weaker and from the slower the quicker?”

Cebes: “Yes, certainly.”

Socrates: “What about this, doesn’t worse come into being from better and the more just from the more unjust?”

Cebes: “How could it be otherwise?”

Socrates: “Do we understand this sufficiently now, that everything comes into being in this way, opposite things arising from opposites?”

Cebes: “Yes, certainly.”

71b

Socrates: “What about this further question? Is there something of this sort, something in between all these pairs of opposites, which is twofold? Are there two processes, one going from one extreme to the other, and a second going in the opposite direction? For there is increase and decrease in between something greater and something lesser, and, accordingly, do we refer to one as increasing and the other as decreasing?”

Cebes: “Yes.”

Socrates: “Doesn’t this happen in all cases, separation and combination, cooling and heating? And even if we sometimes do not use the names, must it not, in fact, always be like this: that they are generated from one another, and there is generation into one another?”

Cebes: “Certainly.”

71c

Socrates: “What about this?” he said. “Is there an opposite of being alive, just as being awake is the opposite of being asleep?”

Cebes: “There is, of course,” he replied.

Socrates: “What is it?”

Cebes: “Being dead.”

71d

Socrates: “Don’t these come into being from one another since they are opposites, and, as there are two of them, aren’t there

two processes in between them?”

Cebes: “There must be.”

Socrates: “Then,” said Socrates, “I shall describe to you one pairing which we just referred to and its processes too, and you should then describe the other one to me. So I say that there is ‘being asleep’ and ‘being awake’, and from being asleep arises being awake, and from being awake arises being asleep, and the processes between the two are falling asleep and waking up. Is that enough for you,” he said, “or not?”

Cebes: “It is certainly enough.”

71e

Socrates: “Then, describe life and death to me on this basis. Don’t you say that being alive is the opposite of being dead?”

Cebes: “I do, indeed.”

Socrates: “And do they arise from one another?”

Cebes: “Yes.”

Socrates: “Then, what is generated from the living?”

Cebes: “The dead.”

Socrates: “And what is generated from the dead?”

Cebes: “I have to admit that it is the living.”

Socrates: “So, Cebes, do those who are alive, and anything that is alive, come into being from those who have died?”

Cebes: “It appears so,” he replied.

Socrates: “So in Hades our souls are.”

Cebes: “So it seems.”

Socrates: “Now, of the two processes involved here, one at any rate is evident, for dying is surely an evident process, is this so?”

Cebes: “Yes, certainly”

72a

Socrates: “Well,” he asked, “how shall we proceed? If we do not balance this with an opposite process, then won’t nature be one-legged in this respect? Isn’t it necessary to assign some process which is the opposite of dying?”

Cebes: “Absolutely.”

Socrates: “What process is this?”

Cebes: “Coming to life again.”

Socrates: “Now, if there is such a thing as coming to life again, would not the coming to life again be the generation of those who are alive, from those who have died?”

Cebes: “Certainly.”

Socrates: “So, we agree that the living come into being from the dead in this way, just as much as the dead come from the living; and since this is the case, it seems there is sufficient proof that the souls of the dead necessarily exist somewhere, and they come into being once more, from there.”

72b

Cebes: “It seems to me, Socrates,” he said, “that based upon what has been agreed, this must be the case.”

Socrates: “Well, if you look at it this way, I think you will see that what we have agreed is right. For if the various processes did not always correspond to one another as if they were going around in a circle, but the generation was always in a straight line, only from something to its opposite, and it never turned back to the other again or went in the other direction, you know that everything would finally have the same form, suffer the same fate, and would stop coming into being.”

Cebes: “What do you mean?” he asked.

Socrates: “It is not difficult to understand what I mean,” he said. “For instance, if there were a process of falling asleep, on the one hand, without any corresponding process of awakening from sleep, you know everything would eventually make Endymion¹⁴ look insignificant, and his great sleep would be of no account because everyone else would be the same as him, asleep. And if everything was combined and nothing was separated, the statement of Anaxagoras¹⁵ that ‘all things were together’ would soon be fulfilled. By the same argument, dear Cebes, if everything which ever partakes of life were to die, and the dead were to remain in that condition once they had died, without coming back to life again, isn’t it totally inevitable that eventually everything would be dead, and nothing would be alive? For if the living were to come into being from other sources, and the living, for their part, were to die, is there any way to avoid everything being consumed by death?”

72d

Cebes: “I do not think so at all, Socrates,” replied Cebes. “Yes, it seems to me that what you are saying is entirely true.”

Socrates: “Yes, Cebes,” he said, “that is how it seems to me. It is truer than any account, and we are not deceived when we agree with all this. Yes, there is, in fact, also a process of coming back to life again, the living do come into being from those who have died, and the souls of those who have died exist.”

72e

Cebes: “And indeed,” Cebes said in response, “if that argument, Socrates, which you are in the habit of recounting so frequently, is true, then according to that, learning for us is nothing other than recollection, and on this basis we must presumably have learned at some previous time what we are now remembering. But this would be impossible unless our soul was somewhere before it took on this human form. So, in this way too, the soul seems to be something immortal.”

73a

Simmias: Simmias interjected and said, “Cebes, what proofs have we for these claims? Please remind me, for I do not remember them very well at present.”

Cebes: “Well,” said Cebes, “one excellent argument is this: if people are asked questions and someone questions them properly, the people, of themselves, describe everything as it is. However, if knowledge and a correct account were not within them, they would not have been able to do this. What is more, if someone shows them diagrams or the like, you have the clearest evidence that this is the case.”

73b

Socrates: “And,” said Socrates, “as you are not quite persuaded by this, Simmias, let us see whether you will agree if you consider it as follows. Do you actually doubt that what we call learning is recollection?”

Simmias: “I do not doubt it,” said Simmias, “but I want to undergo the very process the argument is describing; I want to be reminded. From Cebes’ attempt at the argument, I almost remember it already and I am persuaded. Nevertheless, I would now like to hear how you propose to deal with it.”

73c

Socrates: “It goes like this,” he said. “We agree, of course, that if someone is to be reminded of something, he must have known that very thing on a previous occasion.”

Simmias: “Certainly,” he replied.

Socrates: “Now, do we also agree that whenever knowledge arises in a particular manner, it is recollection? What manner am I referring to? Well, if someone, having seen something or heard it or acquired some other perception of it, were to know not only that thing, but if he also thought of something else, something the knowledge of which was not the same but

different, would we be right to say that he recollected whatever it was that he thought of?"

73d

Simmias: "What do you mean?"

Socrates: "Something like this. Presumably the knowledge of man and of lyre are different."

Simmias: "How could they not be?"

Socrates: "You know that whenever lovers see a lyre or a garment or anything else which a favourite was in the habit of using, their experience is as follows. They recognise the lyre and they apprehend in their mind the figure of the boy who owns the lyre, and this is recollection, as when someone who has seen Simmias is often reminded of Cebes, and presumably there would be thousands of other examples of that sort."

73e

Simmias: "Yes, by Zeus, thousands," said Simmias.

Socrates: "Isn't that sort of thing a recollection, particularly when the experience relates to things which have already been forgotten through time and lack of consideration?"

Simmias: "Yes, certainly," he replied.

Socrates: "What about this?" he asked. "Isn't it possible to be reminded of a man on seeing a picture of a horse, or a picture of a lyre, or to be reminded of Cebes on seeing a picture of Simmias?"

Simmias: "Very much so."

Socrates: "And isn't it possible to be reminded of Simmias on seeing a picture of Simmias?"

Simmias: "It is, indeed."

74a

Socrates: “So, doesn’t it follow from all this that there is recollection arising from likes, but also from unlikes?”

Simmias: “It follows.”

Socrates: “But whenever someone recollects anything from like things, isn’t there something else that must occur to him? Won’t he recognise whether or not the thing lacks anything in respect of its likeness to whatever he is recollecting?”

Simmias: “He must,” replied Simmias.

Socrates: “Well,” he said, “consider if this is how these matters stand. We say, I presume, that there is something equal, not of wood to wood, or stone to stone, or anything else of that sort, but the equal itself, something different besides all these. May we say that there is such a thing or not?”

74b

Simmias: “Indeed, let us say most certainly that there is. It is amazing, by Zeus.”

Socrates: “And do we know what it is?”

Simmias: “Certainly,” he replied.

Socrates: “From where did we obtain the knowledge of this? Isn’t it as we just said? From seeing pieces of wood or stone or other equals, we have brought that equal to mind from these, and that is different from these. Or does it not appear different to you? Think about this too, as follows. Do not equal pieces of wood and stone, being the same, sometimes appear equal to one thing but not to another?”

Simmias: “Yes, certainly.”

74c

Socrates: “What about this? Did the equals themselves ever appear unequal to you, or equality to be inequality?”

Simmias: “Not yet anyway, Socrates.”

Socrates: “Then these equals, and the equal itself, are not the same.”

Simmias: “Not at all, Socrates, not according to me.”

Socrates: “And yet,” he said, “from these equals, which are different from that equal, the knowledge of equality has nevertheless come into your mind and been apprehended.”

Simmias: “What you say is very true,” he said.

Socrates: “Isn’t it either like them or unlike them?”

Simmias: “Certainly.”

Socrates: “But that makes no difference,” he said. “As long as you see one thing and bring something else to mind from this observation, be it like or unlike, recollection must have taken place.”

Simmias: “Yes, certainly.”

74d

Socrates: “What about this?” he said. “Is our experience somewhat as follows in relation to what is in the pieces of wood and in the equals we mentioned just now? Do they appear just as equal to us as the equal just by itself, or do they lack something of that on account of being something that is like the equal, or do they lack nothing?”

Simmias: “They are considerably lacking,” he replied.

Socrates: “Do we not agree that whenever someone sees something and thinks, ‘what I now see is aiming to be like something else among things that are, however, it lacks something and is unable to be quite like that, instead it is inferior’, presumably someone who recognises this must have had prior knowledge of that which he says it has come to resemble, and of which it is falling short?”

Simmias: “He must.”

74e

Socrates: “Well now, is this also our experience in relation to the equals and the equal itself, or is it not?”

Simmias: “Entirely so.”

75a

Socrates: “Then we must have had prior knowledge of the equal before that occasion when we first saw the equals and realised that these are all striving to be like the equal but attain it in a deficient manner.”

Simmias: “This is so.”

Socrates: “But then do we also agree that it is recognised, and can only be recognised from seeing, touching, or one of the other senses? I am saying that these are all the same.”

Simmias: “Yes, Socrates, they are the same, in the context of what this argument is trying to show.”

75b

Socrates: “Well, in any event, we must have recognised from sense perceptions, that all perceptible equals are striving towards what equal is, and are deficient with respect to it. Or how would we express this?”

Simmias: “In that way.”

Socrates: “Then, before we began to see and hear and use the other senses, I presume we must have acquired knowledge of what the equal itself is if we are to refer the equals perceived through the senses to that equal and recognise that everything of this sort endeavours to be like that, but is inferior to it.”

Simmias: “That must follow from what we said before, Socrates.”

75c

Socrates: “Didn’t we see and hear and use the other senses as soon as we were born?”

Simmias: “Certainly.”

Socrates: “Then we must have acquired the knowledge of the equal before we acquired the senses. Is that what we are saying?”

Simmias: “Yes.”

Socrates: “So, apparently we must have acquired this knowledge before we were born.”

Simmias: “So it seems.”

Socrates: “Therefore, if we were born possessing this knowledge, having acquired it before birth, then is it not the case that before we were born, and at birth, we knew not only the equal, and the more and the less, but everything of that sort too? Indeed, this argument is no more concerned with the equal than with beauty itself, good itself, justice, holiness, and as I say, everything to which we apply the term ‘what it is’, both in the enquiries when we ask questions, and in the responses when we answer them. In which case, we must have acquired the knowledge of all these before birth.”

75d

Simmias: “That is it.”

Socrates: “And if after we have acquired it we have not forgotten it every time, we must always be born with the knowledge and live with the knowledge throughout our lives. For that is what knowing is, the retention of knowledge, without loss, once it has been acquired. For we do refer to forgetting as the loss of knowledge, do we not, Simmias?”

75e

Simmias: “Entirely so, Socrates, of course,” he replied.

Socrates: “On the other hand, I presume that if we acquired knowledge before birth and lost it in the process of birth, but later on, by using the senses in this regard, we re-acquired the

knowledge we previously possessed, then what we call learning would be a re-acquisition of our own knowledge. And wouldn't we be right to call this recollection?"

76a

Simmias: "Certainly."

Socrates: "In fact, this was shown to be possible: that once we perceive something by sight or hearing, or apprehend it with some other sense, it is possible to bring something else to mind from this, something we have forgotten, something associated with it, which may be like it or unlike it. Consequently, as I say, there are two possibilities: either we were born knowing these things, and we all know them throughout life, or else later those who we say are learning are merely remembering, and in that case learning would be recollection."

Simmias: "Yes, indeed, Socrates, that's how things stand."

76b

Socrates: "Well, which will you choose, Simmias? Were we born with the knowledge or do we recollect later on what had previously been known?"

Simmias: "I cannot choose just now, Socrates."

Socrates: "What about this? Can you make a choice and form an opinion about the following? Would somebody who knows be able to give an account of what is known or not?"

Simmias: "Yes, this must be so, Socrates," he replied.

Socrates: "And do you think that everyone can give an account of the matters we have just been talking about?"

76c

Simmias: "I wish they could," said Simmias, "but I am very much afraid that this time tomorrow there will no longer be a single person who can do this in a worthy manner."

Socrates: “So it does not seem to you, Simmias, that everyone knows this?”

Simmias: “Not at all.”

Socrates: “Then are they recollecting what was previously learned?”

Simmias: “They must be.”

Socrates: “When did our souls acquire the knowledge of these things? For, evidently, it was not the very moment at which we were being born human beings.”

Simmias: “Of course not.”

Socrates: “So it was before then.”

Simmias: “Yes.”

Socrates: “So, Simmias, even before then, our souls were there, prior to being in human form without bodies, and possessed wisdom.”

76d

Simmias: “Unless we acquire knowledge of these at the time we are being born, Socrates, for that particular occasion still remains for consideration.”

Socrates: “So be it, my friend. But is there some different occasion when we lose it? For we have just agreed that we are not born possessing this knowledge. So do we lose it at the very time we acquire it? Or can you suggest some other time?”

Simmias: “Not at all, Socrates. I was talking nonsense without realising it.”

Socrates: “Well, Simmias, is this how matters stand with us? If, on the one hand, as we are constantly repeating, there is beauty and good, and all being of that kind, and we refer everything from the senses to this being, rediscovering what existed

previously, and is our own, and we compare these to this, then just as surely as these exist so also must our souls exist before we were born. But on the other hand, if these do not exist, this argument would have proceeded differently. So is that how matters stand, is there an equal necessity that these exist and that our souls exist before we are born, and if these do not exist, neither do those?"

76e

Simmias: "Socrates, it certainly seems to me that the necessity is the same," said Simmias, "and the argument has taken refuge, quite beautifully, in the conclusion that the soul's existence before we were born is just as certain as the existence of the being you are now describing. For nothing is so clear to me as the fact that all such things, beauty, good and all the others you just mentioned, exist. Nothing could be more certain and, in my view, this has been adequately proven."

77a

Socrates: "And what about Cebes?" said Socrates. "For it is also necessary to persuade Cebes."

Simmias: "In my view, it is enough for him too," replied Simmias. "However, he is the most obstinate of men when it comes to incredulity in the face of arguments. Now, I believe he has been adequately persuaded that our soul existed before we were born, but whether the soul will continue to exist after we die seems unproven even to me, Socrates. Rather, the point made by Cebes still stands, the fear of the multitude that once a person dies, the soul is dispersed, and this is the end of its being. For why could it not arise and be constituted from some other source and exist before it arrives in human form? But once it has arrived and then departed, couldn't it too then come to an end and be destroyed?"

77c

Cebes: “You expressed that well, Simmias,” said Cebes. “It seems as if what has been proven is half of what is required, that our soul existed before we were born. But it is necessary to add a proof that after we die, it will exist no less than before birth, if the proof is to be complete.”

Socrates: “Well, Simmias and Cebes, that has been proven already,” said Socrates, “provided you combine this argument and the one we agreed upon before this, the one about all the living being born from the dead, into the same argument. For if the soul also exists previously, and it must come to life and come into being from nowhere else but from death and dying, surely it must exist after death since it has to be born again? So the proof you require has already been given. Nevertheless, I think that you and Simmias would also love to pursue this argument even further, and you are afraid, like children, lest, in truth, the wind will blow the soul away and scatter it when it departs from the body, especially if someone happens to die, not on a calm day, but during a strong gale.”

77e

Cebes: Cebes laughed at this, and said, “Try to reassure us, Socrates, as if we were afraid. We are not really afraid, but perhaps there is some child within us who is afraid of such things. So try to persuade him not to fear death, as he fears monsters.”

Socrates: “Then,” said Socrates, “you should sing charms to him every day until this has been charmed away.”

78a

Cebes: “Now, Socrates,” he said, “where are we going to get a good singer of such charms, since you are leaving us?”

Socrates: “Greece is well populated, Cebes, and there are surely many good men there, and the non-Greek peoples are numerous too, so you should search all these thoroughly in

pursuit of such a singer of charms, sparing neither money nor effort, for there is no better way to spend your money than on this. But you should also search with one another for you are unlikely to find anyone more capable of doing this than yourselves.”

78b

Cebes: “Very well,” said Cebes, “this shall be done. However, we should resume the discussion from where we left off, if that is acceptable to you.”

Socrates: “Of course it is acceptable. Why wouldn’t it be?”

Cebes: “Well spoken,” he said.

Socrates: “In that case,” said Socrates, “should we ask ourselves a question like this: to what sort of thing does the fate of being scattered belong, and for what sort of thing should we fear this fate, and what sort of thing escapes it? Then should we go on to investigate which of the two is soul, and on this basis be confident or fearful for our own soul.”

Cebes: “What you say is true,” he said.

78c

Socrates: “Now, doesn’t it belong to something which has been compounded, and which is by nature a compound, to suffer this fate and to be broken up in the same way it was compounded? But if there is anything which is un-compounded, it belongs to this alone, if anything, not to suffer such a fate.”

Cebes: “I think this is true,” said Cebes.

Socrates: “Now, the things which are always the same and unchanging are most likely to be the un-compounded things, while those which are constantly changing and never the same are those which are compounded. Is this so?”

Cebes: “Well, it seems so to me, anyway.”

78d

Socrates: “Then let us go”, he said, “to the same things we discussed earlier. Is the being itself, whose existence we give an account of through question and answer, always unchanging and the same, or is it constantly changing? The equal itself, the good itself, that which each itself is, and ‘what is’, do these ever admit any change whatsoever? Or does that which each of them always is, since it is uniform just by itself, remain the same and unchanging and never admit any alteration in any respect?”

Cebes: “It must remain unchanging and the same, Socrates,” said Cebes.

Socrates: “And what about the many beautiful things, such as people or garments or anything else of that sort, or the many equals, or anything else bearing the same name as those unchanging things? Do these remain the same, or in total contrast to those are they almost never ever the same as themselves or one another in any respect at all?”

78e

Cebes: “Yes, that is the way they are,” said Cebes. “They never remain the same.”

Socrates: “Now, these you can touch and see and perceive with the other senses. However, there is nothing else by which you could ever apprehend the unchanging things, except the reasoning of the mind, but such things are unseen and are not visible. Is this so?”

Cebes: “What you are saying is entirely true,” he replied.

79a

Socrates: “Then would you like us to propose two kinds of things that are, one visible, the other not visible?”

Cebes: “Let us propose that.”

Socrates: “And does that which is not visible always remain the same, while the visible is never the same?”

Cebes: “We should propose this too.”

Socrates: “Come then,” he said, “do we ourselves consist of anything other than body and soul?”

Cebes: “Nothing else.”

79b

Socrates: “Now, which kind do we say the body most resembles and to which is it most akin?”

Cebes: “It is obvious to everyone that it resembles the visible kind.”

Socrates: “What about the soul? Is it visible or invisible?”

Cebes: “It cannot be seen by humans anyway, Socrates.”

Socrates: “But surely we meant visible and invisible in the context of the nature of human beings? Or do you think otherwise?”

Cebes: “No, the context is the nature of human beings.”

Socrates: “Now, what do we say about the soul? That it is visible or that it is invisible?”

Cebes: “It is not visible.”

Socrates: “So it is invisible then?”

Cebes: “Yes.”

Socrates: “So the soul is more like the invisible than the body is, while the body is more like the visible.”

Cebes: “Yes, Socrates, it absolutely must be.”

79c

Socrates: “Well have we not said this before? Whenever the soul makes use of the body to consider anything, either through sight or through hearing or through any other sense – for consideration through the body means considering anything

through the senses – then the soul is dragged by the body to things which never remain the same. It wanders, is confused, and it is dizzy as though drunk because it is in contact with things of that sort.”

Cebes: “Yes, indeed.”

79d

Socrates: “But whenever it considers just by itself, the soul departs to another realm, to the pure, eternal, immortal and unchanging. And since it is akin to this, it is constantly in its presence, whenever it is just by itself and allowed to be so. Then the soul ceases its wandering, associates with these, and remains always the same and unchanging because it is in contact with things of that sort. And this condition of the soul is called wisdom.”

Cebes: “What you are saying is entirely beautiful and true, Socrates,” he said.

79e

Socrates: “Well then, from what we have already said and are now saying, which of the two kinds does the soul seem to you to resemble, and to which is it more akin?”

Cebes: “Socrates,” he replied, “I think that anyone, even the slowest learner, would agree, based upon this approach, that the soul is completely and, in every respect, more like that which always remains the same, rather than that which does not.”

Socrates: “What about the body?”

Cebes: “It is more like the other kind.”

80a

Socrates: “Now, look at it this way. Once soul and body are together, nature directs the body to serve and be ruled, and the soul to rule and dominate. And in these respects again, which of them do you think is like the divine and which like the mortal?”

Or don't you think the divine is naturally fitted to rule and to lead, and the mortal to be ruled and to serve?"

Cebes: "Yes, I do."

Socrates: "Then, which of them does the soul resemble?"

Cebes: "It is obvious, Socrates, that the soul resembles the divine, while the body resembles the mortal."

80b

Socrates: "Then consider this, Cebes," he said. "From everything that has been said, are we to conclude that the soul is most like the divine, immortal, single in form and indissoluble, which is known by reason and always remains unchanging and the same as itself? And is the body, on the other hand, most like the human, mortal, unreasoning, multiform and dissoluble, which never remains the same as itself? Do we have anything to say which contradicts this, dear Cebes, anything which says that this is not the case?"

Cebes: "We have nothing."

Socrates: "Well then, this being the case, doesn't it belong to the body to be readily dissolved, while the soul, for its part, is entirely indissoluble or almost so?"

80c

Cebes: "How could it be otherwise?"

Socrates: "Now, you realise", he said, "that when a person dies, his visible part, the body, lying in the visible realm, the thing we call a corpse, is prone to dissolution, decomposition and dispersal. But none of these processes happens immediately; instead, it endures for quite a long time, and if someone dies while the body is in good condition and at the right time of life, it lasts even longer. Indeed, once the body has shrunk and has been embalmed as the Egyptians embalm them, it remains almost entire for a considerable period of time, and even when

it decays, some parts of the body, bones and sinews and everything of that sort, are virtually immortal. Isn't this so?"

Cebes: "Yes."

80d

Socrates: "But does the soul, the unseen, go to another noble, pure and unseen place of this sort, a true Hades, alongside the good and wise god, whither, God willing, my own soul should go? Is something of this sort, endowed with such a nature, dispersed and destroyed as soon as it departs from the body, as most people say? Far from it, dear Cebes and Simmias. No, the outcome is much more like the following. If the soul were to depart whilst pure, dragging nothing belonging to the body with it, because the soul had no willing communion with it in life but shunned it, and gathered itself into itself because that is its constant practice, then this is nothing but the proper practice of philosophy, and the true practice of dying without reluctance. Or would this not be the practice of death?"

81a

Cebes: "Entirely so."

Socrates: "Once it is in this condition, will the soul not journey to that which is like it, to the unseen, the divine, immortal and wise, and on arrival will blessedness not be its lot, being released from wandering and stupidity, fears and wild passions and the other evils of the human condition? Then, as they say of the initiated, the soul truly spends the rest of the time with the gods. Should we describe it like this, Cebes, or in a different way?"

Cebes: "In this way, by Zeus," replied Cebes.

81b

Socrates: "But if, on the other hand, it departs from the body, sullied and impure, because the soul constantly associates with it, serving it and loving it and being enchanted by it through

desires and pleasures, so that nothing seems to be true except what has bodily form, what one can touch and see, eat or drink, or use for sexual gratification, while anything obscure to the eyes and unseen, known by reason and apprehended by philosophy, is something it tends to hate, fear and shun, do you think that a soul in such a condition will depart pure, just by itself?"

Cebes: "Not at all," he replied.

81c

Socrates: "Rather, when interpenetrated by that which has bodily form, I think this familiarity and association with the body forces the soul to adopt its nature due to the constant association and great concern with the physical."

Cebes: "Yes, certainly."

Socrates: "Well then, my friend, we must accept that this element is burdensome, heavy, earthy and visible. And, indeed, the kind of soul which possesses this is weighed down and dragged once more into the visible realm through fear of Hades and the unseen, and as the story goes, prowls about memorials and tombs, where indeed some shadowy apparitions of souls have actually been seen. These are the visible images of souls of this kind, souls which were not set free in a pure condition but partaking of the visible, and that is why they can be seen."

Cebes: "Quite likely, Socrates."

81d

Socrates: "Yes, Cebes, and it is also likely that these are the souls not of good but of degenerate folk, who are compelled to wander about such places to pay the penalty for their former way of life which was bad. And they wander until they are bound once more in a body by the desire belonging to the bodily form, their close consort. And quite likely, they are bound in such habits as they have practised during life."

Cebes: “What sort of habits do you mean, Socrates?”

81e

Socrates: “For instance, those who have practised gluttony, insolence or drunkenness, rather than avoiding these at all costs, are likely to take on the forms of donkeys or beasts of that sort. Or do you not think so?”

Cebes: “What you are saying is certainly very likely.”

82a

Socrates: “While those who have preferred injustice, tyranny and robbery take on the forms of wolves, hawks and kites. Or where else should we say such souls go?”

Cebes: “Into creatures of this sort, of course,” said Cebes.

Socrates: “And obviously each of the others would take their course based upon the similarities of their concern.”

Cebes: “Yes, that is obvious. How could it be otherwise?”

Socrates: “Will the happiest among them not take the best course, those who have pursued civil and social virtue which they call sound-mindedness and justice, born of habit and concern but devoid of philosophy and of reason?”

Cebes: “In what sense are they happiest?”

82b

Socrates: “Because it is likely that these people return once more to this sort of sociable or gentle class, perhaps as bees, wasps or ants, or even into the human race again, and from them moderate people are born.”

Cebes: “Quite likely.”

Socrates: “However, no one but the lover of knowledge, one who has practised philosophy and departs in an entirely pure condition, is allowed to attain the race of gods. And these are the reasons, Simmias my friend, and you too Cebes, why those

who love wisdom aright abstain from all of the desires of the body and resist them and do not give themselves over to them. It is not because they fear poverty or loss of property, like most people who love wealth; nor again do they refrain from them because they are afraid of dishonour, or a reputation for depravity, like the lovers of power and reputation.”

82d

Cebes: “Indeed, Socrates, that would not be appropriate,” said Cebes.

Socrates: “It certainly would not, by Zeus,” he said. “For in fact, Cebes, those with any concern for their own soul who do not live their lives fashioning bodies bid farewell to these fellows and do not follow the same path as people who do not know where they are going. They do not believe that they themselves should act in opposition to philosophy and the liberation and purifying process it affords, so they turn and follow philosophy wherever it may lead.”

Cebes: “How does this happen, Socrates?”

82e

Socrates: “I shall tell you,” he said. “Those who love knowledge realise that when philosophy takes the soul in hand, it is literally fettered within the body, glued to it, and the soul is compelled to view things that are through the body, as if it were a prison, rather than viewing them itself, through itself. The soul is wallowing in total ignorance, and philosophy discerns the most ingenious aspect of the prison, that it works by means of desires, so that the actual prisoner may be the greatest accomplice in his imprisonment. Now, as I was saying, the lovers of knowledge realise that when philosophy takes their soul in hand in such a condition as this, it exhorts the soul gently and tries to set it free, pointing out that enquiry by means of the eyes is fraught with deceit, and that enquiry by means of the ears and the other senses is also deceptive.

83b

Socrates: “Philosophy persuades the soul to withdraw from the senses and use them only as much as necessary, imploring it to collect and gather itself into itself, trust nothing else except its own self, and what it can cognise just by itself, about things that are, just by themselves. The soul should not believe that what it considers by any other means, things that are different in different circumstances, are true. These are known by the senses and are visible, but what soul sees is known by reason and is unseen by the senses.

Socrates: “Now, the soul of the true philosopher does not think that this liberation should be resisted, and accordingly it refrains from pleasures and desires, pains and fears, as much as it is able to, realising that whenever people experience intense pleasure, pain, fear or desire, the extent of the evil which afflicts them as a consequence is not what they think it is. It is not disease or some financial loss born of desire. No, it is the greatest and most extreme evil of all, this they experience and do not realise it.”

83c

Cebes: “What is this evil, Socrates?” said Cebes.

Socrates: “That whilst experiencing intense pleasure or pain, the soul of every person is compelled to believe that whatever is mainly responsible for the experience is completely evident and entirely true, when this is not the case. And these are, for the most part, visible, aren’t they?”

Cebes: “Yes, certainly.”

83d

Socrates: “Is not the soul completely fettered by the body, in this experience?”

Cebes: “In what way?”

Socrates: “Because each pleasure and pain has a sort of nail which fastens and pins the soul to the body and makes it corporeal, fancying that whatever the body declares to be true is true. For I believe the soul is compelled to become like the body in manner and in nurture because it shares the body’s opinions and it delights in the same things. And it can never enter Hades in a pure condition, but it always departs contaminated with the body, so that it quickly falls into another body and grows there like a seed that is sown. Accordingly, the soul has no share in the company of the divine, the pure, and the unitary.”

83e

Cebes: “What you are saying is very true, Socrates,” said Cebes.

Socrates: “Now, Cebes, that is why those who love knowledge aright are orderly and courageous, and not for the reasons that most people give. Or do you think it is?”

84a

Cebes: “I certainly do not.”

Socrates: “No indeed, the soul of the person who loves wisdom would reason as we have described and would never deign to use philosophy to free itself, and then, once free, give itself over again to pleasure and pain, fetter itself once more, and perform the endless task of Penelope,¹⁶ weaving some web in the opposite direction. Instead, the soul maintains serenity in the face of these, following reason and abiding always in that, beholding what is true and divine and beyond opinion, and being nourished by these. It thinks it should live in this way while it remains alive, and when it dies, arriving among its own kindred and kind, be released from the evils of humanity. Now, there is no danger, Simmias and Cebes, that a soul, nourished in this way, will be afraid once it has practised this, afraid that it may be dispersed on departure from the body, be blown away by the wind, take flight, and no longer be anywhere at all.”

84c

Now, there was silence for quite some time after Socrates had said all this, and it looked as if he himself was reflecting on the discussion which had concluded, and so too were most of us. But Simmias and Cebes were conversing with one another in whispers. When Socrates noticed them, he asked,

Socrates: “What is this? Perhaps you think that these arguments have been poorly presented. Of course, they still afford many grounds for suspicion and points of attack, if someone really intends to scrutinise them properly. Now, if you are considering some other issue, then I have nothing to say. However, if some aspect of these arguments is perplexing you, do not hesitate to state it and scrutinise it yourselves if, in your view, it could have been better formulated. And what is more, you should include me in the discussion if you think you might make better progress with my involvement.”

84d

Simmias: And Simmias said, “In fact, Socrates, to tell you the truth, both of us have been perplexed for some time, one urging the other on and telling him to ask you a question, as we wanted to hear your response. However, we were reluctant to make any trouble, in case it might be unpleasant for you because of the present misfortune.”

When he heard this, Socrates laughed gently, and said,

Socrates: “Oh dear, Simmias, I shall certainly have difficulty in persuading other people that I do not regard my present predicament as a misfortune, when I cannot even persuade you two. Instead, you are afraid that I am more ill-tempered now than I have been all my life. And apparently you think I am less of a prophet than the swans who sing throughout their lives but sing most of all, and most beautifully, once they realise that they must die, rejoicing because they are about to enter the company of the god whom they are serving.

85a

Socrates: “But human beings, on account of their own fear of death, utter falsehoods even about the swans, and say that they sing their song of departure in sorrow, lamenting their death. They do not appreciate that no bird ever sings when it is hungry or cold or suffering any other distress, not even the nightingale or the swallow or the hoopoe, birds which are actually said to be singing lamentations in sorrow. But neither these nor the swans appear to me to be singing in sorrow. I think, rather, that because they are birds of Apollo, swans have prophetic powers, and foreseeing all the good of Hades, they sing and are more delighted on that day than they ever were before. And I myself believe that I am their fellow servant, devoted to the same god, possessing a prophetic power from the lord which is no less than theirs, and I am no more distressed than they are to depart this life. So on that account, you should say or ask anything you want, for as long as the eleven officers of the Athenians allow it.”

85c

Simmias: “That is beautifully expressed,” said Simmias, “and I shall tell you what is perplexing me, and Cebes will, in turn, say why he does not accept what has been said. It seems to me, Socrates, and perhaps to you too, that definite knowledge of such matters is either impossible or extremely difficult in this life. That said, however, it is a very faint-hearted person who does not scrutinise the arguments about these matters in every manner possible, without giving up until totally exhausted by the enquiry. For we should proceed on these issues in one of two ways, either learn or discover how matters stand, or if this is impossible, then adopt the best and most unassailable argument of humankind, climb on board that, as if it were a raft in a perilous sea, and sail upon it through life, unless one can travel on a more secure vessel, some divine word, safely and free from danger. What is more, I will not be ashamed to ask a

question now, in view of what you are saying, nor shall I blame myself later on because I did not say what I am now thinking. Indeed, Socrates, when I consider what has been said, either from my own perspective or from Cebes' perspective, the account does not appear entirely adequate."

85e

Socrates: And Socrates said, "Perhaps this appearance is true, my friend, but you should explain in what way the account is inadequate."

Simmias: "It seems to me inadequate," Simmias said, "in this sense. Someone might propose the very same argument in relation to attunement and a lyre and its strings, saying that the attunement is indeed an unseen, non-physical, entirely beautiful and divine element in the tuned lyre, while the lyre itself and its strings are, by contrast, physical objects with physical form. They are compounds, which are earthly and akin to the mortal. So when someone breaks the lyre, or cuts and severs the strings, if someone were to maintain the same argument as you, he would say that this attunement must still exist and cannot have perished because there would be no way the lyre could still exist with its strings severed, strings that are mortal in nature, while the attunement, which is similar in nature and akin to the divine and immortal, perishes before the mortal perishes. He would claim, rather, that the attunement itself must somehow still exist, and the wood and strings must rot away first before anything happens to that. And in fact, Socrates, I think you yourself are aware that this is the sort of thing we actually take the soul to be. It is as if our body is tempered and held together by hot and cold, dry and moist, and the like, and that our soul is a blend and attunement of these very elements once they are properly mixed with one another in a measured way.

86c

Simmias: “Now, if the soul happens to be an attunement, it is obvious that whenever the body is relaxed beyond measure or is strained by diseases or other evils, the soul, even though it is utterly divine, must perish immediately, just like the other attunements in sounds or in any manufactured objects. And what remains of each body must last for a long time until it is either burned up or rots away.

86d

Simmias: “So consider this, how shall we respond to this argument if someone asserts that the soul, being a blend of elements in the body, is the first thing to perish in what we call death?”

Socrates, as he did so often, stared openly, smiled, and said,

Socrates: “Simmias is making a fair point. Now, if anyone here is more resourceful than I am, why do they not respond to him for he does actually seem to be coming to terms with the argument quite well? However, before we respond, I think it is useful to hear first what further objection Cebes is raising about the argument. That will give us time to decide what we shall say, and then, once we have heard them both, we shall agree with them if their objections seem to ring true in any way, and if not, then we shall proceed to defend the argument at that stage. So come on, Cebes,” he said, “speak up. What else was bothering you?”

87a

Cebes: “Speak I shall,” said Cebes, “for it appears to me that the argument is still in the same predicament and is open to the same objection we stated previously. I will not retract the argument that our soul existed even before it entered this form, as this has been elegantly and, if it is no exaggeration to say so, quite thoroughly proven. However, the argument that it still exists, somehow, after we die, does not seem to me to have been proven. I do not accept Simmias’ point that the soul is less

strong and less enduring than the body, for I think it is far superior in all these respects. So, the argument might ask me, ‘Why are you still incredulous when you can see that the weaker part still exists after the person dies? Do you not accept that the more enduring part must still survive at that particular time?’

87b

Cebes: “Now, determine whether my response to this makes any sense. Indeed, just like Simmias, it seems I shall also need to use an image. For I think that what is being said is quite like the following argument about an old man, a weaver, who has died. Someone might say that the man has not perished but is somehow alive and well, and they might offer the garment he used to wear and which he had woven himself, as evidence, because it is safe and sound and has not perished. And if anyone was unconvinced by this, he might ask them whether a human being is longer lasting than a garment he uses and wears, and having received the answer that the person is much longer lasting, he might think he had proved that the person is alive and well since the less enduring object has not perished. But I do not think that this is the case, Simmias, so consider what I am about to say. Everyone would appreciate that this is a ridiculous argument to propose, because this weaver, having woven and worn out many such garments, has perished after them, although there were many. However, I presume he perished before the last of them and a man is not in any degree inferior to, or weaker than, a garment on that account.

87d

Cebes: “Now, I think the soul’s relation to the body would admit the same comparison, and anyone who uses these very arguments in that context would appear to me to be speaking reasonably, because the soul is long lasting, while the body is weaker and less enduring. He would argue that in fact each of the souls wears out numerous bodies, especially if it lives for many years, for if the body is in flux and is perishing while the

person is still alive, then the soul is constantly weaving anew whatever has been worn away. Yet when the soul perishes, it must be wearing the last garment it wove, and it must perish before that one, and that one alone. And with the perishing of the soul, the body would demonstrate its natural weakness at that stage and would quickly rot away and be gone.

88a

Cebes: “Accordingly, we should not yet deem this argument worthy of belief and be confident that our soul will still exist after we die. For suppose we were to make even more concessions to this disputant than you suggest, and grant to him that our soul exists, not only in the interval before our birth, but concede that there is no reason why, in some cases, it should not still exist even after we die, and continue to exist, and be born and die again many times, as the soul is so strong by nature that it can withstand being born many times. Yet having granted this, we would still not accept that the soul is unaffected during its multiple births, and that it will not come to an end during one of the particular deaths and perish completely. But he would reply that no one has ever known the particular death and the particular dissolution of the body which brings destruction to the soul, since it is impossible for any of us to be aware of it. And if this is the case, it is not appropriate for anyone to have confidence in the face of death, a confidence which is not unreasonable unless he can prove that the soul is completely immortal and indestructible. Otherwise, anyone who is about to die must be in constant fear on behalf of his own soul, lest it perish utterly during its present separation from the body.”

88c

Now, when the rest of us had heard them saying all this, we became unsettled, as we confessed to one another afterwards, because having been strongly persuaded by the previous argument, Simmias and Cebes now seemed to be disturbing us

once more and casting us into doubt, not only in relation to the earlier discussion but also in relation to matters we would discuss later on. We feared that we might not be worthy judges of anything, or even that the issues themselves might be subject to doubt.

Echecrates: By the gods, Phaedo, I have sympathy for you. In fact, when I heard you saying this just now, I started thinking to myself, ‘What argument can we still believe in? The argument presented by Socrates was highly persuasive, but now its credibility has collapsed.’ In fact this argument that our soul is an attunement is extraordinarily captivating to me now, and it always has been, and when you mention this it reminds me that I hold these views already. And I really need some other argument to convince me once more, from the beginning, that the soul of a dying man does not die along with him. So tell me, by Zeus, how did Socrates pursue the argument? And what about the man himself, did he show any sign of being upset like the rest of you, or did he defend the argument calmly? And did he defend it adequately, or were there deficiencies? Tell us everything as precisely as you can.

88e

Phaedo: Well now, Echecrates, I had been amazed by Socrates many times before, but I was never as delighted as I was in his company at that moment. The fact that the man had something to say was not really anything unusual, but I was most amazed: firstly, at the pleasant, gracious and admiring way he accepted the argument of the young men; also by how keenly he discerned how we had been affected by their arguments; and finally by how well he cured us, rallied us as if we were fleeing in defeat, and turned us around to follow him and examine the argument together.

Echecrates: How did he do this?

Phaedo: I shall tell you.

89b

I was sitting to the right of Socrates on a small stool beside the bed and he was seated much higher up than me. He stroked my head and gathered up the hair around my neck, for he was accustomed, on occasion, to play with my hair.

Socrates: “Tomorrow,” he said, “perhaps you will cut off these beautiful locks, Phaedo.”

Phaedo: “Quite likely, Socrates,” I replied.

Socrates: “Not if you let me persuade you.”

Phaedo: “What would happen then?” I said.

89c

Socrates: “I will cut my hair today,” he said, “and you will cut these locks if our argument meets its end and we prove unable to bring it back to life. And if I were you and the argument got away from me, I would take an oath, just like the Argives,¹⁷ not to let my hair grow until I had defeated the arguments of Simmias and Cebes in a fresh battle.”

Phaedo: “But,” said I, “they say that even Heracles could not do battle against two.”

Socrates: “Then,” said he, “call upon me, your Iolaus,¹⁸ so long as it is still daylight.”

Phaedo: “Yes, I shall call upon you,” I said, “but I am no Heracles; I am Iolaus calling upon Heracles.”

Socrates: “It will make no difference,” he said, “but first let us beware that a particular misfortune does not befall us.”

Phaedo: “What?” I asked.

89d

Socrates: “Let us not become haters of discourse,” he said, “just as some people become haters of humanity, for there is no greater evil that could befall a person than developing a hatred

of discourse. But hatred of discourse and hatred of humanity both arise in the same manner. The hatred of humanity arises from placing a strong trust in someone without any experience and believing the person to be entirely true, sound and trustworthy, but finding a little later that he is evil and untrustworthy. And if this happens again with someone else, and the man has this experience frequently, especially with people he regards as his closest acquaintances and best friends, he ends up being buffeted so often that he hates everyone and believes that no one is in any way sound at all. Or have you never noticed this happening before?"

Phaedo: "I have indeed," I replied.

89e

Socrates: "Now," he said, "is this not shameful, and is it not obvious that such a person is attempting to deal with humanity without any experience in human affairs? For presumably, if he had any skill when he dealt with them, he would have realised how matters stand, that those who are extremely good and those who are extremely evil are both rare, while those in between are many."

Phaedo: "What do you mean?" I asked.

90a

Socrates: "Take extremely large and small things as an example. Do you think there is anything rarer than finding an extremely large or extremely small man or dog or any other animal? And does not the same also apply to quick and slow, ugly and beautiful, white and black? Have you not noticed that in all such cases the utmost extremes are rare and few, while those in between are plentiful and numerous?"

Phaedo: "Yes, indeed," I replied.

90b

Socrates: “Do you not think”, he asked, “that if a competition in badness were instituted, very few people would prove to belong in the first rank?”

Phaedo: “Quite likely,” I replied.

90c

Socrates: “Likely indeed,” he said, “but arguments are not similar to people in this respect. No, you gave a lead just now and I followed it. The similarity shows itself rather when someone who lacks any skill in relation to arguments believes a particular argument to be true, and then a little later the argument seems to him to be false, and sometimes this is the case and sometimes it is not, and this happens again and again. And you know that those who have spent a lot of time in disputatious arguments finally decide that they have become the wisest of men, that they alone have realised that there is nothing sound or certain either in the things themselves, or in the arguments, but that all of the things that are, are literally being turned upwards and downwards, as if they were in the strong tides of the Euripus, never constant for a moment.”

Phaedo: “Yes, certainly,” I replied, “what you are saying is true.”

Socrates: “Now, Phaedo,” he said, “would it not be a sad situation if there were, in fact, some true and certain argument that was capable of being understood, and yet, through encounter with some arguments of this sort, the kind which seem true one moment and false the next, a man were to blame not himself or his own lack of skill, but was finally in such pain that he gladly pushed the blame away from himself, onto the arguments, and spent the rest of his life from then on hating and reviling arguments, and was deprived of the truth and knowledge of things that are?”

Phaedo: “Yes, by Zeus,” I replied, “a sad situation indeed.”

90e

Socrates: “Well,” he said, “first and foremost we should guard carefully against this, and never allow into our souls the notion that no arguments are sound. Instead, it is much better to accept that we are not yet in a sound condition ourselves, and that we should take courage and be eager to attain a sound condition, you and the others, for the sake of the rest of your lives, and I for the sake of death itself. Yes, I am unlikely to retain a philosophical approach to this particular issue under the present circumstances, but like highly uneducated folk I may become keen on victory. For whenever such people are debating about something, they do not consider what the argument is about and the status of that. Instead they are eager that whatever they themselves have proposed be accepted by those who are present, and I think that I differ from them only to this extent at present; I am not eager, except incidentally, that what I am saying should seem true to the people here, but that it should seem as true as possible to me. For I reckon, dear friend, and you should note how greedy I am, that if what I am saying happens to be true, it is really good to be persuaded by it. But if, in fact, there is nothing for people who have died, then in this interval before my own death I shall still be less bothersome to the company with my lamentations, and my ignorance will not persist to the last, for that would have been terrible, but it will come to an end quite soon.”

91b

Socrates: “Well, Simmias and Cebes, I am now fully prepared to embark upon the discussion. You, however, if you take my advice, should pay little regard to Socrates, and much more regard to the truth, and if I actually seem to you to be saying anything true then you should agree, but if not, you should resist with every possible argument, being careful lest in my eagerness I deceive both myself and yourselves at the same time, and depart like a bee leaving my sting behind.

91c

Socrates: “Let us proceed then,” he said. “First, the two of you should remind me of what you said, in case I have actually forgotten. Yes, I think Simmias had doubts and was afraid lest the soul, even though it is more divine and more beautiful than the body, might perish before it, as it is in a kind of attunement. I think Cebes, on the other hand, agreed with me over this, that the soul is longer lasting than the body. But he says that it is not obvious to anyone that the soul, having repeatedly worn out many bodies, will not itself perish when it leaves the last body and this may be death, the destruction of the soul, since the body is always perishing unceasingly. So, Simmias and Cebes, are these the issues we need to consider?”

91e

They both agreed that these were the issues.

Socrates: “Now, do you reject all of the previous arguments or do you accept some and reject others?”

“We accept some and reject others,” they replied.

92a

Socrates: “Well,” he said, “what do you say about the argument in which we stated that learning is recollection and, since this is the case, it necessarily follows that our soul existed elsewhere before she was imprisoned in the body?”

Cebes: “I found it wonderfully persuasive at the time,” said Cebes, “and I still do now, more than any argument.”

Simmias: “Yes, indeed,” said Simmias, “I share the same view, and I would be very surprised if I ever found myself holding a different opinion about it.”

Socrates: And Socrates said, “But you will have to hold a different opinion, my Theban friend, if you persist with the idea that an attunement is a compound entity, and the soul is an attunement constituted from the elements of the body once

they are in tune. For I presume you would not accept the suggestion that an attunement may be constituted before there were the elements from which it must be composed. Or would you accept this?"

92b

Simmias: "Not at all, Socrates," he said.

Socrates: "Now, are you aware," he said, "that these are the consequences of what you propose whenever you assert that the soul exists before it enters the form and body of a human being, and on the other hand, that it is constituted from elements that do not yet exist? For your attunement and what you are comparing it to are not really alike; no, the lyre, strings and sounds come into existence first, and they are not tuned at that stage, but the attunement is established last of all, and it is first to perish. So how will this argument be harmonised with the other one, in your view?"

92c

Simmias: "That is not possible at all," said Simmias.

Socrates: "But surely an argument about attunement should be harmonious, if any argument should be."

Simmias: "It should," said Simmias.

Socrates: "Then your argument is not in harmony. So decide. Which of the arguments do you prefer, that learning is recollection or that the soul is an attunement?"

92d

Simmias: "I much prefer the former, Socrates," he replied. "For this occurred to me without any proof, based upon a certain likelihood and plausibility, which is why most people hold this view. However, I am conscious that arguments which construct their proof on the basis of likelihoods are imposters, and if we are not alert to them they are extremely deceptive, both in geometry and in everything else. But the argument about

recollection and learning was expounded through an hypothesis which deserved acceptance. For it was said, I presume, that our soul exists before it enters the body just as surely as its being, bearing the name 'what is', exists. And I am convinced that I have accepted this in an appropriate and correct manner. So, for these reasons, it seems that I must not accept my own or anyone else's assertion that soul is an attunement."

93a

Socrates: "But what about this, Simmias?" he asked. "Do you think it is natural for an attunement, or any other compound entity, to be in a different condition than the condition of the elements from which it is constituted?"

Simmias: "Not at all."

Socrates: "Nor indeed, I imagine, would the compound do anything or experience anything else besides what the elements either do or experience?"

He concurred.

Socrates: "So it is natural for an attunement not to lead the elements it is composed of, but to follow them."

He agreed.

Socrates: "Then an attunement is quite unable to move in opposition, or sound in opposition, or be opposed in any way to its own parts."

Simmias: "Yes, quite unable."

93b

Socrates: "What about this? Is not each attunement by nature an attunement as it has been tuned?"

Simmias: "I do not understand."

Socrates: “Well, if it had been more tuned or tuned to a greater extent, assuming that can actually happen, it would be more an attunement and an attunement to a greater extent. And if it had been less tuned or tuned to a lesser extent, it would be less an attunement and an attunement to a lesser extent.”

Simmias: “Yes, certainly.”

Socrates: “Now, does this also apply to the soul, so that, however slightly, one soul is more what it is than another? Is it more and to a greater extent, or less and to a lesser extent, a soul?”

Simmias: “Not in any way.”

93c

Socrates: “Come on then, by Zeus,” he said, “do we say that one soul has reason and virtue and is good while another has ignorance and wickedness and is bad? And is it true to say this?”

Simmias: “It is true indeed.”

Socrates: “Now, what will any of those who assert that the soul is an attunement say that these things, virtue and the vice, in our souls are? Are they some further separate attunement or non-attunement? And does the attuned soul, the good one, even though it is an attunement, also have another attunement within itself, while the one that is not attuned is just itself and does not have another attunement within it?”

93d

Simmias: “I cannot tell,” said Simmias, “but whoever proposes that hypothesis would obviously be saying something of that sort.”

Socrates: “But we have already agreed that one soul is not more or less a soul than another, and this is the agreement, that one attunement is not more an attunement or an attunement to a greater extent, or less an attunement or an attunement to a

lesser extent, than another one. Is this so?"

Simmias: "Yes, certainly."

Socrates: "And, being neither more nor less an attunement, it is neither more nor less attuned. Is this the case?"

Simmias: "It is."

Socrates: "And does that which is neither more nor less attuned partake of attunement to a greater extent, to a lesser extent, or to an equal extent?"

Simmias: "Equal."

93e

Socrates: "Now, since one soul is no more or less what it is than another one, namely a soul, then it is neither more nor less attuned."

Simmias: "Quite so."

Socrates: "And if it is characterised in this way, it could not partake of attunement, or lack of attunement, to any greater extent, could it?"

Simmias: "It could not."

Socrates: "And what is more, if it is characterised in this way, could one soul partake of virtue or vice to a greater extent than another one, if vice is indeed a lack of attunement and virtue is an attunement?"

Simmias: "Not to a greater extent, no."

Socrates: "Rather, Simmias, according to the correct argument, if soul is indeed an attunement, no soul will partake of vice. For, obviously, an attunement, being completely an attunement, would never partake of lack of attunement."

94a

Simmias: "No, indeed."

Socrates: “Nor, of course, would a soul, being completely a soul, partake of vice.”

Simmias: “No, how could it, based upon what we said earlier, at least.”

Socrates: “So, based upon this argument, we find that the souls of all living beings will be equally good, since souls are by nature equally what they are, namely, souls.”

Simmias: “That is how it seems to me anyway, Socrates,” he said.

94b

Socrates: “And do you think this has been well argued, and would the argument have ended up in this predicament if the hypothesis that the soul is an attunement was correct?”

Simmias: “Not at all,” he replied.

Socrates: “What about this?” he asked. “Of all the elements in a person, is there anything else that rules, according to you, except soul, especially if it also possesses understanding?”

Simmias: “I do not think so.”

94c

Socrates: “Now, does it act in agreement with the affections of the body or in opposition to them? I mean, in situations where there is heat or thirst within the body, soul draws it in the opposite direction, away from drinking, and when there is hunger, it draws the hunger away from eating, and presumably we are aware of countless other examples of the soul opposing the affections of the body. Is this not so?”

Simmias: “Yes, certainly.”

Socrates: “Furthermore, did we not agree earlier that if the soul is an attunement, it would never strike a note in opposition to the tensions, relaxations, vibrations or any other experiences

which its constituents undergo; rather, it would follow them and never act as leader?”

Simmias: “We did agree,” he said, “how could one disagree?”

94d

Socrates: “But look, do we not now find the soul exemplifying behaviour which is the complete opposite, leading all these elements of which some say it is composed, opposing them throughout life in almost everything, and dominating them in every way? Sometimes it chastises them more severely with painful processes based upon gymnastics, or medicine, sometimes more gently by threatening and admonishing, talking to the desires, passions and fears as though they constituted a separate entity. I suppose it is like what Homer wrote in the *Odyssey*, where Odysseus says: He smote his breast and rebuked his heart with the words, ‘Endure, my heart, you have endured far worse.’¹⁹

94e

Socrates: “Now, do you think he wrote this in the belief that soul is an attunement, the sort of thing which is led by the affections of the body, rather than leading them and dominating them, as it is a far more divine entity than any attunement?”

Simmias: “By Zeus, Socrates, I do not think so.”

95a

Socrates: “Then, my excellent friend, it is not at all appropriate for us to state that soul is an attunement, for it seems we would be disagreeing with the divine poet Homer and with ourselves.”

Simmias: “That is how matters stand,” he said.

Socrates: “In that case,” said Socrates, “it seems we have somehow placated the Theban goddess, Harmonia, quite well. But Cebes,” he said, “what about Cadmus,²⁰ how shall we placate him, and with what argument?”

95b

Cebes: “I think you will find a way,” said Cebes. “At least you presented this last argument, the one about attunement, wonderfully, and contrary to what I expected. For while Simmias was describing his difficulty, I really wondered if anyone would be able to come to terms with his argument. So I thought it was remarkable when it failed to withstand the first attack of your argument. Now, I would not be at all surprised if the argument of Cadmus were to suffer the same fate.”

Socrates: “Good man,” said Socrates, “do not be boastful in case some malign influence overturns the impending argument. Anyway, God will take care of that while we, grappling like Homeric heroes, should try to find out if you are saying anything significant. And the essence of what you are looking for is this: you are asking to be shown that since our souls are indestructible and immortal, a man who loves wisdom and who is confident when he is about to die will not be demonstrating an irrational and foolish confidence by believing he is going to fare well when he gets there, better than if he died after living a different sort of life. But as for showing that the soul is strong and divine and had a previous existence before we were born as human beings, you say that all these facts may just as easily indicate not immortality, but only that the soul is long lasting and has somehow existed for a considerable period of time and has known and done a great deal. But in fact that did not make it any more immortal. Rather, this entry into a human body was the beginning of its demise, just like a disease, and the soul lives this life in suffering and finally perishes in what we call death.

95d

Socrates: “You also say that it makes no difference whether it enters a body once or many times, as far as the fear death holds for us is concerned. Indeed, unless he is stupid, it is appropriate for someone to be afraid when he does not know and is unable to uphold in argument that the soul is immortal. So Cebes, I

think these are the sort of issues you are raising, and I am deliberately going over them again and again in case anything escapes us, or there is anything you may wish to add or retract.”

95e

Cebes: “No,” said Cebes, “there is nothing I need to add or retract at the moment, and these are the issues I am raising.”

Socrates paused for a long time, and he was considering something to himself.

Socrates: “Cebes,” he said, “the question you are pursuing is not trivial, for it involves comprehensive deliberation about the cause of generation and destruction. I shall recount my own experiences of these topics, if you wish. Then, if anything I say proves helpful to you with regard to the reassurance you are referring to, you may make use of it.”

Cebes: “Well, I certainly want that,” said Cebes.

96a

Socrates: “Then listen to what I am going to say,” he said. “When I was young, Cebes, I was extraordinarily eager for that wisdom which they call the science of nature. To me it seemed magnificent to know the causes of each thing, why each thing comes into being, why it perishes and why it is. And I was constantly changing my direction back and forth, asking, firstly: do living creatures develop when hot and cold bring about some fermentation, as some people say? Is it the blood with which we think, or is it air or fire? Or is it actually none of these but rather the brain which provides for the senses of hearing, seeing and smelling, from which arise memory and opinion and once memory and opinion have acquired stability, does knowledge arise on the basis of them? And then going on to consider their corruption, and the things that happen in the heavens and on the earth, I finally deemed myself naturally unsuited to this sort of investigation, almost useless.

96c

Socrates: “I will give you enough evidence as follows: before this, there were certain things I knew quite well, or so it seemed to me and to others, but later on I was so utterly blinded by this investigation that I unlearned what I previously thought that I knew about many other matters, and even about why a person grows. Before this, I thought it was obvious to everyone that this is due to eating and drinking. For from the food that is eaten, flesh is added to flesh, bone to bone, and through the same process, their own substance is also added to the other parts, and eventually the lesser bulk becomes greater and this is how the small person becomes big. That is what I thought at the time. Does that sound reasonable to you?”

96e

Cebes: “To me, yes,” said Cebes.

Socrates: “Then consider this too. I used to regard it as acceptable for me to think that whenever a man standing beside a small man appears large, it is on account of the head itself that he is larger, and the same goes for horses. And it seemed even more evident to me that the ten is greater than the eight because the two is added to them, and the two cubits are greater than the one cubit because it exceeded it by half its length.”

Cebes: “Yes, but what do you think about these matters now?” asked Cebes.

97a

Socrates: “By Zeus,” he said, “I am far from convinced that I know any of the causes of these things, when I cannot even accept for myself that whenever someone adds one to one, either the one to which it is added has become two, or that the added one and the one to which it is added became two, due to the addition of the former to the latter. For I am amazed that when each of them was apart from the other, each was somehow one and neither then was two, and yet, once they

drew near to one another, this was, in itself, somehow the cause of their becoming two, this coming together in which they are placed near one another.

97b

Socrates: “Nor can I ever persuade myself that if someone divides one, this division is itself the cause of its becoming two. For this cause of its becoming two turns out to be the opposite of the previous cause. Previously it was because they were drawn together, close to one another, and were added to each other, but now it is because they are drawn apart, and separated from each other. Neither can I ever persuade myself that I know how one arises, nor for that matter how anything else comes into being, or perishes, or is, based upon this manner of approach. No, I do not accept this at all, and instead I somehow devise an alternative manner of approach of my own.

97c

Socrates: “But one day I heard someone reading from a book which he said was by Anaxagoras, which was saying that reason is what sets things in order and is the cause of everything. Now, I was pleased with this explanation, and it somehow seemed appropriate to me that reason is the cause of all, and I decided that if this is the case then reason, as it is ordering everything, orders and arranges each thing in the best possible manner. Therefore, if someone should wish to discover the cause according to which each thing comes into being, perishes, or is, then he needs to discover the best way for that thing to be, or undergo, or enact anything at all. And so, based on this account, a person should consider nothing else about himself or about anything else, except what is most excellent and best. And then the same person necessarily knows what is worse, for the knowledge concerned with both is the same.

97d

Socrates: “As I reflected on all this, I was delighted to think I had found a teacher of the cause of the things that are, whose

reasoning was in accord with my own. I thought Anaxagoras would also tell me first whether the earth was flat or round, and when he had told me that, he would also explain the cause and necessity thereof, describing what is best and why it was better for the earth to be like that. And if he said it was in the centre, he would go on to explain that it was better for it to be in the centre. And if he could clarify these issues for me, I had resolved not to long for any other kind of cause. What is more, I had resolved to conduct an enquiry into the sun and the moon and the other stars in the same manner, their speed relative to one another, their inclinations and their other characteristics, and the precise way in which it is better for each of them to behave as they do, and to undergo whatever happens to them. Indeed, once he had stated that these are ordered by reason, I never thought he would attribute any other cause to them, except that it is best for them to be in the state they are actually in. Therefore, I thought that in assigning the cause to each of the things and to all of them together, he would go on to explain what is best for each of them, and good for all of them together. And I would not have traded these hopes for anything. No, I acquired the books eagerly and read them as quickly as I could, so that I would know the best and the worst as quickly as I could.

98b

Socrates: “Well, my friend, my wonderful hope was wrenched away from me when I continued with my reading and beheld a man neither having recourse to reason nor assigning to it any responsibility for the ordering of things but assigning responsibility to air and ether and water and numerous other oddities. And he seemed to me to be behaving just like someone who says that anything Socrates does is done on account of reason. But then, when he tries to state the causes of each action I perform, he might say, firstly, that the explanation for my sitting in this place now is that my body is constituted from

bones and sinews, and the bones are hard and have joints separating them from one another, while the sinews, which can be tensed and relaxed, surround the bones, as does the flesh and the skin which encloses them. Well, since the bones are dangling in their own sockets, the tightening and loosening of the sinews now enables me somehow to bend my limbs, and this is the cause of my sitting here with my legs bent. And likewise with regard to our conversation, he might also propose other causes of this sort, describing sounds, air currents, auditory experience and countless other such factors as causes, neglecting to mention the true causes, that once the Athenians had decided it was better to condemn me, I in turn decided it was indeed better for me to sit here, because it was more just to remain and submit to whatever penalty they might dictate. Since, by the dog, I am sure these bones and sinews would have been in Megara or Boeotia long ago, impelled by an opinion about what was best, if I had not thought it more just and noble to submit to whatever penalty the city might impose, rather than taking flight and running away.

98d

Socrates: “But to refer to such factors as causes is most absurd. And yet, if anyone were to say that without having such things as bones and sinews, and anything else I possess, I would be unable to do whatever I decide to do, he would be speaking the truth. To say, however, that I do what I do because of these, and that I also perform them on account of reason, and not on account of choosing what is best, would show a very great disregard for the argument. Imagine being unable to make the distinction between the actual cause, on the one hand, and that in the absence of which the cause would never be a cause, on the other hand. Yes, it seems to me that most people are groping about in the dark, and making use of an inappropriate name, when they refer to this as a cause. And on this basis, some place a vortex about the earth, and make the earth remain in

place on account of the heavens, while others support the earth just like a flat dish resting upon air. But the power by which these are now situated in the best way that they could have been placed is a power which they neither look for nor credit with any divine strength. Instead they believe they will eventually discover some Atlas²¹ who is stronger and more immortal than this, who will do a better job of encompassing them all, and it never occurs to them that, in truth, the good and the right bind and encompass. Now, I would gladly have become the pupil of anyone at all in order to learn the precise nature of such a cause as this. However, since this was denied me and I proved unable either to find it myself or learn from someone else, would you like me, Cebes, to give an exposition of how I undertook the second sailing in search of the cause?" he asked.

99c

Cebes: "Yes, I would like that very much," he replied.

99d

Socrates: "Well, after this, since I was exhausted from studying the things that are, it seemed to me that I should beware lest I suffer the fate of those who look at the sun and study it during an eclipse. For some of them, as you know, destroy their eyes unless they study its image in water or something of that sort. I also arrived at a similar understanding, and I was afraid that my soul might be totally blinded by looking at things with the eyes and trying to grasp them with each of the senses. So it seemed to me that I should take refuge in arguments, and study in these the truth of the things that are. Now, perhaps my comparison is in a sense inappropriate, for I do not really agree that someone who studies the things that are, through arguments, has more recourse to images than someone who studies them in actualities.

100a

Socrates: “Anyway, I set about this in the following manner. In each case, I hypothesise an account which I judge to be the strongest, and I regard as true anything which seems to me to be in harmony with this, whether it concerns a cause or anything else at all, and I regard anything which does not, as untrue. But I would like to explain what I am saying to you more clearly for I do not think you understand at the moment.”

Cebes: “No, by Zeus,” said Cebes, “not completely.”

100b

Socrates: “Well, this is what I mean,” he said. “It is nothing new. No, it is just what I have been constantly repeating, both in the argument which has just been presented and on other occasions. Indeed, I am going to attempt to show you the kind of cause I have worked on, and I am going back again to topics which have been discussed repeatedly, and I am starting from those, proposing that there is beauty just by itself, and good, and largeness, and all the others. And if you grant me these and agree that they exist, I hope, from these, to show you the cause and to confirm that the soul is immortal.”

100c

Cebes: “Well, in that case,” said Cebes, “you may assume that I grant you this and you should lose no time in proceeding with the account.”

Socrates: “Then consider the consequences of these admissions,” he said, “and whether they seem to you as they do to me. For it appears to me that, if anything else is beautiful except beauty itself, then it is beautiful because it partakes of that beauty and for no other reason. And I say the same about all the others. Do you accept this sort of cause?”

Cebes: “I accept it,” he replied.

Socrates: “Well, then,” he said, “I no longer understand, nor am I able to recognise those other wise causes, but if someone says

to me that anything at all is beautiful because of the bright colour it has, or its shape, or anything else of that sort, I dismiss the others, for I am confused by them all. And I myself maintain, simply, plainly, and perhaps foolishly, that nothing else makes it beautiful, except the presence of that beauty or communion with it, regardless of the manner or means by which these occur, for I am not making a definite assertion about this yet. But I do assert that all beautiful things are beautiful on account of beauty. And this seems to me the safest answer to give to myself or anyone else, and once I hold to this, I believe I shall never fall. Rather, it is safe for me or anyone at all to answer that beautiful things become beautiful on account of beauty. Or does it not seem that way to you?"

Cebes: "That is how it seems."

100e

Socrates: "And so, are large things large, and larger things larger on account of largeness, and smaller things smaller on account of smallness?"

Cebes: "Yes."

101a

Socrates: "Then you would not accept it if someone were to say that one person is larger than another on account of a head, and the smaller person is smaller on account of this same thing. Instead, you would affirm that you are only saying that everything which is larger than another is larger on account of nothing except largeness, and is larger because of this, because of largeness; and the smaller is smaller on account of nothing else but smallness, and is smaller because of this, because of smallness. I think you would be afraid in case some counter-argument might oppose you, if you were to state that someone is larger or smaller on account of a head: firstly, because you say the larger is larger and the smaller is smaller on account of the same thing; and secondly, because you say the

larger is larger on account of the head which is small, and of course it is preposterous that anyone is large on account of something small. Would you not be afraid of these responses?"

101b

Cebes laughed and replied,

Cebes: "I would, indeed."

Socrates: "Would you not be afraid", he said, "to state that ten is more than eight on account of two, and exceeds it because of this cause, rather than on account of quantity, and because of quantity? And that the two cubits are greater than the one cubit on account of half, and not on account of largeness? Yes, I presume you would have the same fear."

Cebes: "Very much so," he replied.

101c

Socrates: "What about this? Would you not beware of saying that if one is added to one, the cause of their becoming two is the addition, or in the case where it is divided, the division? Instead, you would shout loudly that you know no other way that each arises except by participating in the being particular to each of those in which it participates. And in the examples we are discussing, you know no other cause of becoming two except by participation in duality, and whatever is to be two must participate in this, and whatever is to be one must participate in unity. But those divisions and additions and other subtleties of that kind you would set aside, leaving it to those who are wiser than you are to give those answers. Instead, you would be afraid, as they say, of your own shadow and of your inexperience, and would adhere to that safe hypothesis and would answer based upon that.

101d

Socrates: "Yet, if someone were to adhere to the hypothesis itself, you would ignore him and would not respond, until you

had considered whether the consequences of that were, in your view, concordant or discordant with one another. And when you had to give an account of the hypothesis itself, you would do so in the same way, by proposing another further hypothesis which seems best of those which are higher, until you arrive at something adequate. But you would not confuse matters, as the disputatious people do, by discussing the principle, and the consequences of it at the same time, if you really wanted to discover any of the things that are. Indeed, these fellows do not have a single scruple or concern about this, for they are enabled by their wisdom to jumble everything together, and yet they are still able to be content with themselves. But you, if you really are among the lovers of wisdom, will, I believe, do as I suggest.”

102a

“What you are saying is completely true,” said Simmias and Cebes together.

Echecrates: By Zeus, Phaedo, of course Simmias and Cebes did. Indeed, I think he has explained this with extraordinary clarity to anyone with even a little intelligence.

Phaedo: Yes, certainly, Echecrates, and everyone who was present thought so too.

Echecrates: Yes, and so do those who were absent but are listening to you now. Well, what else was said after all this?

Phaedo: As I recall, when these points had been conceded to him and it was agreed that each of the forms is something and the other things have acquired the names of the forms themselves by partaking of them, he proceeded to ask the following:

102b

Socrates: “Now,” said Socrates to Cebes, “if you describe matters in this way and you say that Simmias is larger than Socrates and smaller than Phaedo, are you not then saying that

both largeness and smallness are in Simmias?”

Cebes: “I am, indeed.”

Socrates: “More to the point,” he said, “are you agreeing with the statement ‘Simmias is taller than Socrates’, when the words used do not actually express the truth? For presumably Simmias is not, by nature, taller than I am on account of being Simmias, but on account of the largeness he happens to possess. Nor, again, is he taller than Socrates because Socrates is Socrates, but because Socrates has smallness relative to Simmias’ largeness.”

Cebes: “True.”

102c

Socrates: “Nor again, is he less tall than Phaedo because Phaedo is Phaedo, but rather because Phaedo has largeness relative to Simmias’ smallness.”

Cebes: “That is it.”

Socrates: “So in this way Simmias is referred to as being both large and small, as he is between both of them, allowing the smallness to be exceeded by the greatness of one person, and presenting to the other the greatness that exceeds that man’s smallness.”

102d

And he smiled at this and said,

Socrates: “I seem to be speaking like a legal document, but anyway the situation is certainly as I am describing it.”

Simmias agreed.

Socrates: “Now, I am saying this for the following reason, I want you to hold the same opinion as I do. For it appears to me not only that the large itself never consents to being large and small at the same time, but also that the large in us never admits the small, nor consents to being exceeded. Instead, there

are two possible outcomes, either it departs and withdraws whenever its opposite, the small, approaches, or else it perishes once the small arrives. But it never consents to being different from the very thing that it is, by waiting about and admitting smallness. Just as I, having admitted and endured smallness, and still being just what I am, I, this same person, am small. But that large has never ventured to be small, and in like manner, the small that is in us never consents to become large or to be so, nor do any of the other opposites, while still being just what they are, also become and be opposite. No, in that circumstance they either depart or perish.”

103a

Cebes: “Entirely so,” said Cebes, “that is how it appears to me.”

And having heard this, one of the company – I do not remember exactly who it was – said, “By the gods, in our earlier discussions, did we not agree the very opposite of what we are now saying? Did we not say that the greater arises from the lesser and the lesser from the greater, and in short, the actual generation of opposites is from opposites? But now I think we are saying that this would never happen.”

103b

Having turned his head to listen, Socrates said,

Socrates: “You have been very brave to remind us. However, you are not recognising the difference between what we are saying now and what we said then. For we were saying then that the opposite thing arises from the opposite thing. Now, however, we are saying that the opposite itself, be it in us or in nature, would not ever become opposite to itself. For then, my friend, we were talking about whatever possessed the opposites, referring to them by the name of the appropriate opposites. Now, however, we are discussing the opposites themselves, whose name the objects bear because those opposites are within them. And we are saying that the opposites themselves would

never be prepared to undergo conversion into one another.”

103c

And at that point he looked at Cebes, and said,

Socrates: “What about you, Cebes? I presume you were not bothered by any aspect of what our friend here said?”

Cebes: “No,” said Cebes, “that’s not how I feel just now, though I am not denying that there are numerous issues bothering me.”

Socrates: “So we have agreed without reservation,” said Socrates, “that the opposite will never be opposite to itself.”

Cebes: “Entirely so,” he replied.

103d

Socrates: “Then consider whether you also agree with me about the following. Do you call something hot or cold?”

Cebes: “I do.”

Socrates: “And are they identical with fire and snow?”

Cebes: “By Zeus, I do not think so.”

Socrates: “Rather the hot is something different from fire, and the cold something different from snow.”

Cebes: “Yes.”

Socrates: “Then I presume you appreciate that, as we said earlier, being snow it will not ever admit heat and still be just what it is, snow, and also hot. Instead, at the approach of heat it either withdraws from it or perishes.”

Cebes: “Certainly.”

103e

Socrates: “And fire also either slips away or perishes when cold approaches, but it will never venture to admit the coldness and still be just what it was, fire, and also cold.”

Cebes: “What you are saying is true.”

104a

Socrates: “Then,” he said, “in some cases like this, the position is that the form itself is not the only thing that always merits the same name forever, but there is also something else which is not that form but always possesses a feature of that form whenever it exists. But perhaps what I mean will be even clearer with this example, for presumably the odd must always be assigned this name which we are now using. Is this not so?”

Cebes: “Certainly.”

Socrates: “But is this the only thing that is assigned this name? That is my question. Or is there something else which is not identical with the odd, but which nevertheless must always be referred to by this name along with its own name, because by nature it is never devoid of the odd? I am referring, for instance, to how the number three and many others are characterised. Think about the number three. Does it not seem that you must always refer to it by its own name and by the name of the odd, although the odd is not identical with the number three? But nevertheless, three, five, and half of all numbers, although they are not identical with the odd, each of them is always odd. And furthermore, two, four, and all the other series of numbers, are nevertheless always even in each case, though they are not identical with the even. Do you agree or not?”

104b

Cebes: “How could I disagree?” said Cebes.

Socrates: “Then take note of what I am trying to show you. It is as follows. It is evident, not only that those opposites do not admit one another, but also that whatever things are not opposite to one another, but always contain opposites, seem not to admit that form which is opposite to the form they contain. Rather, when it approaches, they either perish or withdraw. Or shall we deny that the number three would prefer to perish or suffer any other fate rather than wait about, still being three,

and become even?”

104c

Cebes: “It certainly will,” said Cebes.

Socrates: “And yet, two,” he said, “is not the opposite of three.”

Cebes: “Definitely not.”

Socrates: “So it is not only the opposite forms that do not wait about as they approach one another, but some other things also do not wait about as the opposites approach.”

Cebes: “What you are saying is very true.”

Socrates: “Now, would you like us, if we are able, to define what sort these are?”

Cebes: “Very much so.”

104d

Socrates: “Well, Cebes, would they be those which always compel whatever they take hold of to adopt not only their own form, but also the form of some additional opposite?”

Cebes: “What do you mean?”

Socrates: “Just what we were saying a moment ago, for you know of course, that whatever the form of three takes hold of, it must not only be three but also odd.”

Cebes: “Certainly.”

Socrates: “Then we are saying that the opposite form to the form that produces this would never come to something of this sort.”

Cebes: “It would not.”

Socrates: “Now, does oddness produce this property?”

Cebes: “Yes.”

Socrates: “And is the form of the even the opposite of this?”

Cebes: “Yes.”

104e

Socrates: “So the form of the even will never come to the number three.”

Cebes: “Certainly not.”

Socrates: “Then the number three has no share in the even.”

Cebes: “No share.”

Socrates: “So the number three is uneven.”

Cebes: “Yes.”

105a

Socrates: “Well, I said we were to define the sort of things which, although not opposite to something, nevertheless do not admit it, the opposite. For example, the number three, although it is not opposite to the even, does not admit the even to any extent, for three always imposes the opposite of the even, and two imposes the opposite of the odd, fire the opposite of cold, and there is a whole range of other instances. Now, decide whether they are defined in this way: not only does an opposite not admit an opposite, but there is also that which imposes some opposite upon whatever it approaches, and that imposer itself will never admit the opposite of that which it imposes. But let me remind you again, as it is not a bad idea to hear this very often. The number five will not admit the even, nor will its double, ten, admit the odd. Now, double itself is also the opposite of something, but nevertheless it will not admit the form of the odd, nor will one-and-a-half and other such numbers, like the half and the third, and all numbers of that sort, admit the form of the whole. Do you follow and do you agree that this is the case?”

105b

Cebes: “Yes, I agree most emphatically,” Cebes replied, “and I am following.”

Socrates: “Then recount this to me once more from the beginning,” he said. “And do not answer on the basis of my question, but by imitating what I am doing. I am saying that beyond the first answer I gave, the safe one, I see another safe answer emerging from the present discussion. For if you were to ask me, by the presence of what will the body be hot, I shall not give you the safe answer, the stupid one, that it is by the presence of heat, but a more subtle answer based on this discussion, that it is by the presence of fire. And if you should ask, by the presence of what will the body be ill, I shall not reply that it is by the presence of illness, but by the presence of fever. Nor would I say that a number is made odd by the presence of oddness, but by the presence of a unit, and so on for the other instances. But let us check at this stage whether you understand adequately what I mean.”

105c

Cebes: “Very adequately,” Cebes said.

Socrates: “Then answer this question,” he said, “by the presence of what will the body be alive?”

Cebes: “By the presence of soul,” he replied.

105d

Socrates: “Is this not always the case?”

Cebes: “How could it be otherwise?” he said.

Socrates: “Then soul, whatever it takes hold of, always arrives bringing life to it?”

Cebes: “Yes, that is how it arrives,” he said.

Socrates: “And is there or is there not something opposite to life?”

Cebes: “There is,” he replied.

Socrates: “What?”

Cebes: “Death.”

Socrates: “Now, based on what we agreed earlier, is it not the case that soul will never admit the opposite of that which it imposes?”

Cebes: “It certainly will not,” said Cebes.

Socrates: “Well then, what did we call that which does not admit the form of the even a moment ago?”

Cebes: “Uneven,” he said.

Socrates: “And that which does not admit the just, and that which does not admit the musical?”

105e

Cebes: “Unmusical, and unjust,” he said.

Socrates: “So be it. And what shall we call that which does not admit death?”

Cebes: “Immortal,” he said.

Socrates: “Now, soul does not admit death, does it?”

Cebes: “No.”

Socrates: “Then soul is immortal.”

Cebes: “Immortal.”

106a

Socrates: “So be it,” he said. “Now, may we say that this has been proved? How does it seem to you?”

Cebes: “Yes, very adequately, Socrates.”

Socrates: “What about this, Cebes?” he asked. “If it were also necessary for the uneven to be imperishable, could the number three be anything other than imperishable?”

Cebes: “No, how could it be?”

106b

Socrates: “And if it were also necessary for the ‘un-hot’ to be imperishable, whenever someone brought heat to bear upon snow, would not the snow withdraw, intact and un-melted? For it could not be destroyed, nor again could it wait about and admit the hotness?”

Cebes: “What you are saying is true.”

Socrates: “And in the very same way, I presume, if the un-coolable was indestructible, then whenever something cool approached fire, fire could never be extinguished, nor could it perish, but would depart intact and go away.”

Cebes: “It must,” he said.

106c

Socrates: “And must we not also say the same thing about the immortal?” he asked. “If the immortal is also imperishable, it is impossible for soul to perish whenever death approaches her. For as we said earlier, it will not admit death nor will it be dead, just as we said the number three will not be even, nor for that matter, will the odd be even, nor will fire be cold, and neither will the heat within the fire. But someone might say the odd does not become even at the approach of the even. We have agreed this, but why could it not perish and the even arise in place of the odd? To someone who says this, we would not be able to contend that it does not perish, for the uneven is not imperishable. Indeed, if this point were conceded to us, we could easily have contended that once the even approaches, the odd and the number three depart and are gone, and we could offer a similar contention about fire and heat and the other instances. Is this not so?”

Cebes: “Yes, certainly.”

106d

Socrates: “And therefore, in the present discussion about the immortal, if it were conceded to us that it is also imperishable,

then soul too would be imperishable as well as being immortal, but otherwise some other argument would be required.”

Cebes: “But no other argument is required for this purpose,” he said, “for if the immortal, being everlasting, is going to admit destruction, nothing else could avoid admitting destruction at all.”

Socrates: “Yes,” said Socrates, “and I think it would be agreed by everyone that God, and the form of life itself and anything else that is immortal, will never perish.”

Cebes: “Yes, by Zeus,” he said, “by every human being, and in my opinion, even more so by the gods.”

106e

Socrates: “Now, since the immortal is also indestructible, wouldn’t the soul, if it happens to be immortal, be imperishable too?”

Cebes: “It simply must be.”

Socrates: “So when death comes to a person, it seems that the mortal part dies, while the immortal departs and goes on its way intact and indestructible, giving way to death.”

Cebes: “So it appears.”

107a

Socrates: “So we have all the more reason to accept, Cebes, that soul is immortal and imperishable, and, in truth, our souls will exist in Hades.”

Cebes: “Well, Socrates,” he said, “I do not have anything else to say against these arguments, nor do I doubt them in any respect. But of course, if Simmias or anyone else here has anything to say he had better not remain silent. Because if someone wants to say or hear anything about such matters, I do not know of any other occasion to which he can postpone the present opportunity.”

Simmias: “And yet,” said Simmias, “I too have no further grounds for doubt on the basis of what is being said. However, on account of the vast subject that the arguments are dealing with, and being wary of human weakness, I am bound to harbour additional doubts within myself in relation to what has been said.”

107b

Socrates: “Not only are you right,” said Socrates, “to say that, Simmias, but you should examine the initial hypotheses in greater clarity in any case, even if you believe them yourselves. And if you analyse them properly, I think you will follow the argument to the greatest extent that anyone can follow it. And once this has become clear, you will seek nothing further.”

Simmias: “What you are saying is true,” he said.

107c

Socrates: “But my friends,” he said, “it is right to bear in mind that if, in fact, the soul is immortal, it requires care, not only for the sake of the interval of time which we call ‘life’ but for the sake of all time, and, indeed, if anyone should neglect the soul the danger now seems to be terrible. For if death were an escape from everything, it would be a god-send for the wicked to die, and be freed from the body, and their own wickedness along with the soul. Now, however, since the soul turns out to be immortal, there would be no escape from evils or any salvation for it, apart from becoming as good and wise as possible. For the soul goes to Hades, possessing nothing else except its education and its nurture, which are indeed said to afford the greatest benefit or harm to the person who has died, at the very outset of the journey to that place.

107d

Socrates: “And accordingly, it is said that when each person dies, the daimon of that person, which has been assigned throughout life, is responsible for leading them to some place

where those who are gathered, having undergone judgement, must journey to Hades along with that guide who has been given the task of conducting people from this place to that place. But once they are there and have met what they needed to meet and have remained for as long as necessary, another guide brings them back here again over numerous lengthy cycles of time. So, the journey is not as Aeschylus' Telephos²² describes it. For he says that a simple path leads to Hades, but to me it appears to be neither simple nor single. If it were simple, no guide would be required, for presumably no one could go wrong anywhere if there were only one path. But it now seems that it has many forks and crossroads, and I think this is evident from the sacrifices and rituals which are offered in this world.

108a

Socrates: “Now, the orderly and wise soul follows the guide and is not unaware of its surroundings, while the soul which is possessed of desires of the body, as we said before, flutters around the body and about the visible region for a long time. After much resistance and a lot of affliction, the soul is led away forcibly and reluctantly by its appointed daimon and it departs. Now, the soul which is unpurified and has acted in that sort of manner, having engaged in unjust killings or other activities of the kind which are akin to these, and are the deeds of kindred souls, does arrive where the others are. But everyone shuns the soul and turns away from it, and has no desire to become its travelling companion or its guide. Instead the soul wanders in utter perplexity until certain periods of time have elapsed, and when these are over, it is borne by necessity to the abode appropriate to it. But each soul that has spent a life in purity and measure encounters gods as its travelling companions and guides, and inhabits the region appropriate to it.

108c

Socrates: “Now, someone has convinced me that the regions of the earth are many and wondrous, and it has neither the

qualities nor the extent presumed by those who usually describe it.”

108d

Simmias: And Simmias asked, “What do you mean, Socrates? Of course I have heard a great deal about the earth myself, but not these descriptions which have convinced you. So I would love to hear them.”

Socrates: “Well, Simmias, I do not think the skill of Glaucus²³ is needed to describe, in detail, what they are. However, it appears to me that it is beyond even the skill of Glaucus to show that they are true, and what is more, perhaps I might be unable to do it. And even if I had the knowledge, I do not think my own life is now long enough for such a lengthy discourse. Yet there is nothing to stop me from describing the form which I am convinced the earth has, and the regions it possesses.”

108e

Simmias: “But even that much is sufficient,” said Simmias.

Socrates: “Well,” he said, “I am convinced, firstly, that if the earth is in the centre of the universe and is round, it does not need anything to prevent it from falling, either air or any other constraint of that sort. Rather, the homogeneity of the universe itself with itself in every direction and the even balance of the earth itself are sufficient to hold it. For an evenly balanced object placed in the centre of something homogeneous will not be able to turn more in one direction than in another. Instead, being in a situation of homogeneity, it remains motionless. So that is the first thing I am convinced of,” he said.

109a

Simmias: “And rightly so,” said Simmias.

Socrates: “Now, the next point is that it is absolutely enormous, and we who dwell between the Pillars of Heracles and the river Phasis²⁴ inhabit a tiny part of it, living around the sea like ants

or frogs around a pool, while many others dwell elsewhere in lots of other regions of this sort, for there are numerous hollows all over the earth of various forms and sizes, into which water, mist, and air have gathered together. But the earth itself is pure and it rests in the pure region of the universe where the stars are situated, the region which most people who usually discuss such matters call the ether.

109c

Socrates: “In fact, water, mist, and air are the sediment of ether, and they constantly flow together into the hollows of the earth. But we are unaware that we are living in its hollows and think we inhabit the upper surface of earth. It is as if someone living down in the depths of the ocean were to think he was living on the sea, and beholding the sun and the other stars through the water, believed that the sea was the sky. Due to his lethargy and weakness he would never get to the sea’s surface, nor would he behold how much purer and more beautiful is this region than that of his fellows by coming to the top of the water and popping out his head, nor would he hear about this from someone else who had seen it. Well, our predicament is the same as his, for we inhabit some hollow of the earth and believe that we are dwelling on its surface, and we refer to the air as the heaven because the stars move through this as if it were a heaven.

109d

Socrates: “But, in fact, due to our weakness and lethargy, we are unable to make our way to the furthest extremity of air. Yet if someone were to get to its upper limit, or became winged and flew there, he could stick his head up and have a look, and just as fishes who stick their heads out of the sea can behold whatever is in this region, he would likewise view whatever is in that region. And if his nature were up to the task of sustaining the observation, he would realise that this is the true heaven, the true light, and the true earth. For this earth here, and the

stones and the entire region we are in are corrupted and eroded just as objects in the sea are affected by the brine, and nothing worthy of note grows in the sea, and almost nothing is perfect there. Rather, there are caverns and sand and huge amounts of mud and mire wherever there is any earth, and nothing at all is worthy of comparison with the beauties of our region. But those beauties would, in turn, prove to be superior to the beauties of our realm to an even greater extent. And now, if it is appropriate to tell a story, it is worth hearing, Simmias, what the things upon the earth, that is beneath the heaven, happen to be like.”

110b

Simmias: “In that case, Socrates,” said Simmias, “we would be glad to hear this story.”

Socrates: “Well then, my friend, it is said, firstly, that if anyone views the earth itself from above, it looks just like those balls made from twelve pieces of leather, painted with distinct colours, of which the colours in our region are just like the samples used by painters. But in that place, the earth is entirely composed of such colours, and of colours that are much brighter and purer than those. For one part is purple and its beauty is wondrous, another is golden, and anything white is whiter than chalk or snow, and the earth is composed of other colours in the same way, colours even more numerous and more beautiful than all we have seen. What is more, those hollows themselves, being filled with water and air, exhibit a kind of colour, glistening amidst the variety of other colours, so that the earth appears as one continuous variegated surface.

110d

Socrates: “But since that is what this earth is like, whatever grows there grows in conformity with this principle, be they plants, flowers or fruits. And what is more, in like manner, mountains and stones, in conformity with the same principle,

have smoothness and transparency and more beautiful colours, and the pebbles which are prized among us – sards, jaspers, emeralds and all the like – are fragments of those, but in that place there are no stones that are not like those and even more beautiful than those. And the reason for this is that the stones there are pure and have not been corroded and corrupted like ours by filth and brine, due to everything that flows into this place, influxes which bring deformity to stones, earth and the like, and diseases to plants and animals. But that earth itself has been adorned with all these beauties, and also with gold and silver and other materials of that sort, for these are naturally in evidence as they are plentiful, large, and they are everywhere upon the earth. Consequently, to behold that earth is a vision which is a blessing to those who look upon it. And there are many other creatures there, and humans too, some dwelling inland, others living close to the air, just as we live close to the sea, some on islands surrounded by air, and close to the mainland. And in short, as we have recourse to water and the sea, so do they have recourse to air, and as we have recourse to air, so do they have recourse to the ether.

111b

Socrates: “Their seasons are so temperate that the people are free from disease, and their span of life is much longer than it is here, and in sight, and hearing, and wisdom, and in everything of that sort, they exceed us to the same extent that air exceeds water, and ether exceeds air, in respect of purity. And in fact, they have sacred groves and temples in which the gods really do reside, and utterances, prophecies, awareness of the gods, and any communion of that sort is conducted by them directly with the gods themselves. And the sun, moon, and stars are seen by them just as they actually are, and their general blessedness is a consequence of these blessings.

111c

Socrates: “Now, although the entire earth and the details thereof are thus by nature, there are in fact many regions within it corresponding to the hollows it has all around its entire surface. Some are deeper and wider than the place in which we are dwelling, others are deeper but they have a lesser expanse than our region, and there are others too which are shallower in depth and broader than ours. These are all interconnected beneath the earth in various ways, by channels, some narrow, some wider, and these have outlets from which lots of water pours from one region into the other, as if it were flowing into mixing bowls. And there are enormously large, ever-flowing rivers of both hot and cold water beneath the earth. And there is a great deal of fire and huge rivers of fire and of molten earth, some of which are even more filthy, like the rivers of mud which flow in front of the lava in Sicily, while others are purer, like the lava itself. And in fact, each of the regions is filled by these as the circular flow happens to arrive at each in turn. These all move upwards and downwards just like a kind of seesaw present within the earth. The nature of the oscillation itself is something like this: one of the chasms in the earth happens to be particularly large and it is bored right through the entire earth. This is the one Homer refers to when he says, ‘Far off in the lowest depth beneath the earth...’²⁵

112a

Socrates: “And elsewhere, he and many other poets have named it Tartarus. For all of the rivers flow into this chasm and flow out again from this, and each becomes like the kind of earth through which they flow. But the reason why all the streams flow in and flow out of there is that this liquid has no bottom or base, so it oscillates and surges up and down, and the air and the wind associated with it do the same. For they follow the liquid whenever it gushes to the remote parts of the earth or to these parts. And just as those who are breathing continually inhale and exhale the flowing breath, so also does

the wind there oscillate along with the liquid, giving rise to terrible and enormous gales as it goes in and goes out.

112b

Socrates: “Now, whenever the water withdraws to the region which we call lower, it flows through the earth into the channels that are there and fills them as if it were being pumped. And whenever it leaves there again and surges back here, the streams here are filled once more, and once they have been filled they flow through the channels and through the earth, and when each arrives at the region to which it has been given passage, it makes seas, lakes, rivers and springs. And from there they dive beneath the earth, and when some have gone around the more numerous larger regions, and others have gone around the less numerous smaller regions, they discharge once more into Tartarus, some far below, others a little below where they were pumped out. But they all flow in below where they flowed out, although some flow in directly opposite to the point where they left, others below the same point. There are some that go around in a complete circle, coiling around the earth either once or even many times, like snakes, and having descended as low as possible, they discharge once more. It is possible to descend in either direction as far as the centre but no further, because to both streams the part on either side is uphill.

112e

Socrates: “Now, these streams are numerous, large and variegated, but among this multiplicity are four in particular and the largest and outermost of these, flowing around in a circle, is called Oceanus. Directly opposite to this, flowing in the opposite direction, is Acheron which flows through various desert places, but more significantly, it flows under the earth reaching the Acherusian lake where most souls of the dead arrive and abide for an allotted time, longer in some cases but shorter in others, and are sent back once more to be born as

living creatures.

113b

Socrates: “The third river issues forth midway between these two, and close to its point of exit it emerges into a vast region burning with a lot of fire, and it makes a lake of boiling water and mud larger than the sea in our region. It proceeds in a circle from there, foul and muddy, winding about through the earth in various places and arrives at the shores of the Acherusian lake without commingling with its waters. After many windings under the earth, it discharges beneath Tartarus and this is the river they refer to as Periphlegethon, and from this the lava streams shoot forth their branches from the earth in a random manner.

113c

Socrates: “Directly opposite to this the fourth river issues forth, initially into a terrible and wild region which is said to be entirely coloured like lapis lazuli and is referred to as the Stygian region, and the lake made by the discharging river is the Styx. Now, once it has poured in there and has acquired formidable powers in the water, it dives beneath the earth and proceeds to circle about in the opposite direction to Periphlegethon and meets it in the Acherusian lake coming from the opposite side. Neither does it mingle with the waters of the lake, rather this river goes around in a circle and discharges into Tartarus opposite Periphlegethon. And the name of this, according to the poets, is Cocytus.”²⁶

113d

Socrates: “This is the nature of these regions. Once those who have died arrive in the region to which the daimon guides each one, they first submit to judgement, some having lived in a noble and sacred manner, others not. Now, those who are judged to have lived middling lives, proceed to the Acheron, get on board vessels which are somehow provided for them, and arrive at the lake on these. There they dwell, and if anyone has

done any injustice he is purified of the injustices, makes retribution and is freed from them. And they receive the rewards of their good deeds, each according to their deserts. But those who are judged incurable because of the magnitude of their transgressions, having carried out numerous and grave sacrilegious acts, or many unjust killings contrary to law, or any other deeds of that sort, these people the appropriate fate casts into Tartarus never to emerge again.

114a

Socrates: “But those who are judged curable, though they committed great transgressions such as doing some violence in anger to a father or mother, and living the rest of their lives in repentance, or being involved in homicides under similar circumstances, these people necessarily fall into Tartarus. Once they have fallen in and spent a year there, the surge sends forth the homicides along the Cocytus and those who have assaulted father or mother along the Periphrægethon. They are carried along, and whenever they get to the Acherusian lake they shout and cry out in that place to the people they have slain or the people they have assaulted. With their cries, they plead and beg that they be allowed to come out into the lake and to be accepted, and if they persuade these people, out they come and that is the end of their afflictions. But if they do not persuade them, they are carried again into Tartarus and from there they enter the rivers once more, and this happens to them unceasingly until they persuade the people they have wronged. For this particular penalty has been imposed upon them by the judges. But the people who are judged to have lived with exceptional holiness, are the ones who are set free from those places beneath the earth as though they are being released from prisons. They arrive above in the pure abode and they dwell upon the earth. Of these people, the ones who have purified themselves sufficiently through philosophy live thereafter without bodies for all time, and they arrive at dwellings even

more beautiful than those, which are not easy to describe, nor is there enough time just now. But as a consequence of everything we have been discussing, Simmias, we must make all efforts to partake of virtue and wisdom in this life, for the reward is beautiful and the hope is great.

114d

Socrates: “Now, it would not be appropriate for a man of intelligence to insist that matters are as I have recounted them. But that these considerations, or something like them, are applicable to our souls and their dwelling places, in view of the fact that the soul turns out to be immortal, seems to me a hazard worth taking, for the hazard is beautiful and appropriate to someone who holds this view of the soul. And he should chant to himself as though they were charms and that is why I have been lengthening the story just now.

114e

Socrates: “So, these are the reasons why a man should be confident about his own soul once he has bidden farewell, in this life, to the various pleasures and adornments associated with the body because they are alien. And realising they are more inclined to have the opposite effect, has busied himself with learning and adorned the soul, not with an alien adornment but with its own, with sound-mindedness, justice, courage, freedom and truth. And in this condition he awaits the journey to Hades, ready to make that journey whenever destiny may call. Well, Simmias and Cebes,” he said, “you and the others will each in turn make the journey at some stage, but now, as someone in a tragedy might say, ‘Destiny is already calling me’, and it is almost time for me to make my way to the bath. Indeed, I think it best to drink the poison after bathing and not give to the women the task of washing a corpse.”

115b

Crito: Well, once he had said all this, Crito said, “So be it, Socrates, but what directions do you have for these men or for

me concerning either your children or anything else? What is the greatest service we could perform for you?"

Socrates: "I shall say what I always say, Crito, nothing new, that in caring for yourselves you will be doing a service to me and mine and to yourselves, whatever actions you may perform, even if you make no promises now. But if you do not care for yourselves, and are not prepared to live your life based upon the path which accords with the declarations we have made now and on previous occasions, even if you make a lot of fervent promises now, you will accomplish nothing."

115c

Crito: "In that case," he said, "we shall strive earnestly to do as you ask. But in what way should we bury you?"

115d

Socrates: "Any way you like," he replied, "that is if you can catch me and I do not escape you."

With this he laughed gently, looked towards us and said,

Socrates: "Friends, I cannot persuade Crito that I am this Socrates who is conversing with you right now and arranging each topic of discussion. Instead, he thinks I am the one he will see in a short time as a corpse, and he asks how he should bury me. I presented extensive arguments a while ago, that once I drink the poison I shall no longer remain with you, but shall depart and be gone to some delights of the blessed. But I think these have been spoken to him in vain, while consoling both yourselves and myself at the same time. Therefore, give an assurance about me to Crito," he said, "the opposite assurance to the one he gave the jurors. For he assured them that I would remain but you must assure him that I shall not remain after I die but will depart and be gone, so that Crito may bear this more easily. And when he sees my body being burned or buried, he may not be troubled on my account as though I am being

treated dreadfully, or say at the funeral that Socrates lies before us or is borne to the grave or buried. For mark my words well, excellent Crito, speaking improperly is not only wrong in itself, but it also engenders an evil in our souls. Instead, you must take heart and say that you are burying my body and bury it as you please and as you deem most appropriate.”

116a

Having said this, he got up and went to another room in order to bathe. Crito followed him but he told us to wait. So we waited conversing among ourselves about what had been said and considering it once more, and then we went on to recount the extent of the misfortune which had befallen us, literally believing that we had been deprived of a father and would spend the rest of our lives as orphans. Once he had bathed the children were brought to him, for he had two small sons and a big one, and the women of his household arrived and he conversed with them, in Crito’s presence, and gave the instructions he wished to give. He then asked the women and children to depart and he himself returned to us.

116b

Now, at that stage the sun was almost setting for he had spent a lot of time within. When he came back after bathing he sat down, but not much was discussed after that, and the servant of The Eleven arrived, stood before him and said,

116c

Warder: “Socrates, I shall not find in you the fault I find in others, whereby they are angry with me and curse me when, on the instructions of the Archons, I order them to drink the poison. During your time here I have known you as the noblest, gentlest, most excellent man who ever arrived in this place. What is more, I know quite well that you are not angry with me now but with them, for you realise who is responsible. Now then, since you know what I have come to announce, fare you well and try to bear what must be as lightly as you can.”

116d

And with this he began to weep, turned away and departed. And Socrates looked toward him and said,

Socrates: “Fare you well too. We shall do as you ask.”

Then he said to us,

Socrates: “What a courteous man! Throughout my time here he has visited me and conversed with me sometimes and has been the best of men, and now, see how genuinely he weeps for me. But come now, Crito, let us pay heed to him. Let someone bring the poison if it has been pressed and if not, the man should press it.”

116e

Crito: And Crito said, “Socrates, I think the sun is still upon the hills and has not yet set. What is more, I know that others have drunk the poison very late, whenever the announcement has been made to them. They have feasted and drunk quite a lot, some of them even fraternising with people they happen to enjoy. So do not rush, there is still time.”

Socrates: And Socrates replied, “Crito, it is quite reasonable for these people to do this, the people you describe, for they think there is benefit in doing so. And it will be reasonable for me not to do so, as I think there is no benefit in drinking the poison a little later, apart from becoming a figure of fun to myself by clinging to life and sparing what is already spent. So come on,” he said, “heed me and do not refuse me.”

117a

And when Crito heard this he nodded to his servant who was standing nearby and the boy went out, was gone for quite some time, and returned bringing the man who was going to administer the poison, carrying it already pressed in a cup. When Socrates saw the man, he said,

Socrates: “So be it, best of men, since you are knowledgeable about these matters, what should I do?”

117b

Poisoner: “Nothing,” he said, “except drink this and walk about until your legs become heavy, then lie down and in this way the poison will act by itself.”

And as he said this he held out the cup to Socrates. And having taken it most graciously, Echecrates, without fear or any change of colour or expression, but looking at the man wide-eyed, as usual, he said,

Socrates: “What do you say about pouring a libation to someone from this cup? Is that permitted or not?”

Poisoner: “Socrates,” he replied, “we only press the amount we think you need to drink.”

117c

Socrates: “I understand,” he said, “but it is permitted and indeed necessary to pray to the gods that my change of abode from here to there be graced with good fortune, and so I pray that this may be so.”

And as he said this, he put the cup to his lips and very calmly and without flinching, he drank it down. Up to then most of us were able to restrain our tears fairly well, but when we saw him drinking and saw that he had drunk it, we could do so no longer. In spite of myself, my own tears flowed in a torrent, and so I hid my face, weeping not for him but for myself and my own misfortune at being deprived of such a companion. And even before that, when Crito was unable to restrain his tears, he had moved away. But Apollodorus, who had been weeping incessantly before then, broke out at this stage into such wailing and grieving that none of the company could help breaking down, except Socrates himself.

117d

Socrates: “Strange men,” he said, “what a way to behave! I sent the women away mainly so that they would not cause such a tumult, for I have also heard that it is necessary to die in reverent silence. So keep quiet and endure.”

117e

And when we had heard this we felt ashamed and refrained from weeping. He walked around until he said that his legs were becoming heavy, then he lay flat on his back as the man had instructed, and this man who had administered the poison began examining him, and when some time had passed he probed his feet and legs and then he pinched his foot hard and asked if he could feel it. He said, “No.” And after this the man felt his shin once more, and working upwards in this way he showed us that he was going cold and stiff. And again, he touched him and said that when it reached the heart, he would then be gone.

118a

Now, once the coldness was somewhere in the region of his groin he uncovered his face, for it had been covered, and said, and this was his final utterance,

Socrates: “Crito, we owe a cock to Asclepius,²⁷ so pay the debt without fail.”

Crito: “Yes, it shall be done,” said Crito, “but see if you have something else to ask for.”

To this question he did not even reply. After a short time he shuddered and the man uncovered him, and his eyes were fixed. And when Crito saw this he closed the mouth and the eyes.

Phaedo: Such was the end, Echecrates, of our companion, a man whom we would say was the best, the wisest too, and the most just of any we have ever known.

NOTES

1. Phaedo was a close associate of Socrates, and eventually set up a philosophical school in Elis.
2. Echecrates was a Pythagorean philosopher from Phlius, near Corinth.
3. According to legend, King Minos required the Athenians to send fourteen youths each year to his kingdom on the island of Crete to be sacrificed to the Minotaur. Theseus is reputed to have saved the youths and slain the monster, thus freeing the Athenians from this annual tribute.
4. The nine men listed here from Athens and the surrounding area were part of Socrates' inner circle. A few of them appear in other of Plato's dialogues: Apollodorus appears in Plato's *Symposium*; Crito, the father of Critobulus, lends his name to Plato's *Crito*; Hermogenes is the main interlocutor in Plato's *Cratylus*; Ctesippus is mentioned in both Plato's *Lysis* and *Euthydemus*; Menexenus has a small part in Plato's *Lysis* and has a dialogue named after him. Epigenes and Aeschines are both mentioned in Plato's *Apology* as having been present at the trial of Socrates; the latter was a writer of Socratic dialogues. Antisthenes is regarded as the founder of the Cynic school of philosophy.
5. Simmias, Cebes and Phaidondes were Pythagoreans from Thebes, north of Athens; Euclides and Terpsion were from Megara, a city west of Athens. The first two are mentioned in Plato's *Crito* as having raised enough money to secure Socrates' escape. Euclides was also a writer of Socratic dialogues, and founder of the Megarian school of philosophy.
6. Cleombrotus was a young follower of Socrates who was reputed to have taken his own life after reading the *Phaedo*. Aristippus was the founder of the Cyrenaic school of philosophy.
7. Among the 700 magistrates of Athens appointed by lot, eleven men, simply called 'the Eleven', were in charge of prisons and executions.
8. Xanthippe was Socrates' wife. They had three children, two who were young men and a third still young enough to be carried by his mother.
9. Aesop was a legendary storyteller to whom a collection of fables was attributed.
10. Evenus of Paros was a late 5th-century sophist and teacher. He is also mentioned in Plato's *Apology* (20b-c) and *Phaedrus* (267a).
11. Philolaus was an influential Pythagorean philosopher from southern Italy. He spent some time in Thebes, where he met Simmias and Cebes.

12. The mysteries and rites of initiation referred to here are those that were associated with Orpheus.
13. This quote contrasts the true worshippers of Dionysus, the Bacchae, with those who merely carry the outward symbols of such worship, i.e. the thyrsus, a giant fennel stalk covered with ivy.
14. Endymion was a beautiful mortal who was granted eternal youth by Zeus, who put him into an everlasting sleep, all at the request of Selene.
15. Anaxagoras was a natural philosopher from Clazomenae in Ionia, who lived a generation before Socrates. His influence upon Socrates is described later in the dialogue.
16. Penelope was the wife of Odysseus. She had promised to marry one of her suitors once she finished weaving a shroud for her father-in-law. In order to deceive the suitors, she wove by day and undid each day's work by night. Thus, her task of weaving was endless. *Odyssey* ii.92-105.
17. The men of Argos swore an oath not to let their hair grow until they had defeated the Spartans in battle.
18. Iolaus was the nephew of Heracles, who assisted his uncle in some of his Labours.
19. *Odyssey* xx.17-18
20. Cadmus was the legendary founder of Thebes, and his wife was Harmonia, daughter of Ares and Aphrodite. Socrates plays here upon their reciprocal relationship.
21. Atlas was a Titan who was condemned to hold up the sky for all eternity after the Titans were defeated in their war against the Olympians.
22. Aeschylus' work *Telephos* no longer survives.
23. A common adage of uncertain origin.
24. The Pillars of Heracles refers to promontories that frame the entrance to the Strait of Gibraltar. The River Phasis is situated in modern-day Georgia and flows into the Black Sea.
25. *Iliad* viii.14, 481.
26. The geography of the underworld is drawn from Homer's *Iliad* and *Odyssey*, especially *Odyssey* x.511 ff, xi.157.
27. Asclepius, the son of Apollo, born a mortal but deified after his death, was the god of healing. Sick people who slept in his sanctuary, having been cured, would often sacrifice a cock to him.

Phaedrus

ΦΑΙΔΡΟΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

PHAEDRUS a young Athenian

scene: outside the city walls of Athens, by the Ilissus river

227a

Socrates: Dear Phaedrus, where are you going to and where are you coming from?

Phaedrus: I have been with Lysias, the son of Cephalus,¹ and I am going for a walk outside the walls for I have spent a long time sitting with him since early this morning. On the advice of Acumenus,² your friend and mine, I take my walks on the open roads, for he says that these walks are more refreshing than those through the streets.

227b

Socrates: Indeed, my friend, he is right to say so. Anyway, it seems that Lysias has been in town.

Phaedrus: Yes, staying with Epicrates, in the house that belonged to Morychus,³ near the Olympieum.

Socrates: Well then, how did you spend the time? Or is it obvious that Lysias entertained you with speeches?

Phaedrus: You will find out if you have the time to come along and listen.

Socrates: What is this? Don't you realise that, as Pindar puts it, I shall accord 'a higher status than any other business'⁴ to hearing how you and Lysias spent your time?

227c

Phaedrus: In that case, lead on!

Socrates: Please tell me.

Phaedrus: Very well, Socrates. Anyway, it is appropriate that you hear this. You see, the speech on which we spent our time

was, in a certain sense, concerned with love. Yes, in fact, Lysias wrote about some beautiful fellow being tempted, but not by a lover. That was the clever aspect of this, for he says that one should favour a non-lover more than a lover.

Socrates: How noble! But I wish he would write that one should favour the poor rather than the rich, or the old rather than the young, and refer to qualities which I and so many others possess. Then the arguments would really be clever and of public benefit. Anyway, I am so enthusiastic to hear you that I will not leave you, even if you take a walk as far as Megara and, like Herodicus,⁵ go back once more when you reach the city walls.

227d

Phaedrus: What are you saying, excellent Socrates? Do you think that I, an amateur, could recall speeches which Lysias, the most formidable writer alive, composed at leisure over a considerable period of time, in a manner worthy of the author? Far from it, and yet that is an ability I always wanted to have more than any amount of gold.

228a

Socrates: Oh Phaedrus! If I do not know Phaedrus then I have also forgotten myself. But since neither of these possibilities is the case, I know quite well that when listening to Lysias' speech he did not hear it only once, rather he asked the speaker to repeat it many times and the speaker obeyed eagerly. But this was not enough for him, and in the end he got his hands on the script and studied whatever interested him most. He sat doing this from early morning, grew tired and went out for a walk, and I believe, by the dog, he had learned the speech by heart, unless it was particularly long. And as he was going outside the wall to rehearse it, he met someone suffering from a love of hearing discourses, and when he saw him he was delighted to have a fellow enthusiast and he bid him 'lead on'. Yet when this

lover of discourses asked him to speak he gave himself airs, as if he was not so keen to speak. But in the end he was going to speak anyway, even if no one was prepared to listen. So, Phaedrus, you should ask him to do now what he will soon do in any case.

228c

Phaedrus: In truth, the best course by far is for me to speak in the way that I can since I do not think you will ever release me until I speak somehow, in some way.

Socrates: Yes, what you are thinking about me is entirely true.

Phaedrus: Then that is exactly what I shall do. Now, the fact is, Socrates, I certainly have not learned the words by heart. However, I have an understanding of almost all those sections in which he says the lover and the non-lover differ, and I shall give a summary of each aspect in turn, beginning with the first.

228d

Socrates: Yes, dearest, when you have first shown me what exactly you are holding in your left hand underneath your cloak. Indeed, I suspect you have the actual speech. And if that is what it is, then you must appreciate that although I do love you very much, you cannot really expect that I shall allow you to practise on me when Lysias is actually present. So come on, show it to me.

Phaedrus: Stop! You have robbed me of the hope I had of practising on you. Now, where would you like to sit so that we may read it?

Socrates: Let us turn off here and go along the Ilissus, then we can sit quietly wherever you please.

Phaedrus: It seems fortunate then that I happen to be barefoot, and you, of course, always are. So, it is very easy for us to walk along in the stream and bathe our feet, not an unpleasant prospect, especially at this time of year and this hour of day.

228e

Socrates: Lead on then, and let us keep our eye out for somewhere we may sit.

Phaedrus: Well, do you see that lofty plane tree?

Socrates: I do.

Phaedrus: There is shade there and a moderate breeze and grass to sit upon, or even to lie upon should we so wish.

Socrates: Please lead on.

229a

Phaedrus: Tell me, Socrates, wasn't it from somewhere around here that Boreas is said to have snatched Orithyia from the banks of the Ilissus?⁶

Socrates: Yes, that is what they say.

229b

Phaedrus: Was it from here, then? The brook is delightful anyway, and it looks clean and bright and suitable for maidens to play alongside.

Socrates: No, it was from two or three stades further downstream, at the place where we cross over to Agra, and I think there is an altar to Boreas at the spot.

229c

Phaedrus: I have never actually noticed it. But by Zeus, tell me Socrates, do you believe that this story is true?

Socrates: Well, if I disbelieved it as the wise men do I would not be unusual. In that case, I would declare sagaciously that Boreas, the north wind, blew her off the nearby rocks as she was playing with Pharmacea, and of course, having died in this way, she was said to have been borne away by Boreas. Or else it was the Areopagus, for they tell another story in which she is snatched away from there and not from here. Now, Phaedrus, I regard such explanations in general as delightful, but they are the

province of a very clever, hard-working, not entirely fortunate person, who, because of this account, also needs to correct our understanding of the nature of Centaurs and then of Chimeras. And a host of such creatures floods in – Gorgons, Pegasi, and an unimaginable multitude of other extraordinary legendary animals. If someone who does not believe in these stories tries to make them sound reasonable through recourse to some common-sense wisdom, such a person will be very busy, but I have no time whatsoever for them. I will tell you the reason, my friend. I am not yet able, in the words of the Delphic inscription, to ‘know myself’. In fact, investigating extraneous matters while I am still ignorant of this appears ridiculous to me. So, I bid farewell to these issues. I accept the traditional views about them as I have just explained, and I do not investigate them, but I investigate myself instead. Am I, perchance, some beast more complex and more lustful than Typho,⁷ or a gentler and simpler creature endowed by nature with a divine and unpretentious fate? But look, my friend, to interrupt our discussion, isn’t this the tree you were leading us to?

230b

Phaedrus: Yes, this is it.

Socrates: Well, by Hera, this is a really beautiful place to rest. The plane tree itself is so broad and tall. See the height and the glorious close shade of the agnus castus, and how it is in full bloom, filling the place with the finest scent. The most delightful spring beneath the plane tree is flowing with the coolest water, as my foot can testify. And from the statuettes and shrines, it seems the place is sacred to some Nymphs and to Achelous.⁸

230c

Socrates: And what is more, the airiness of the place is so attractive and intensely pleasant, echoing clear and summer-like with the chorus of the cicadas. Most exquisite of

all is the grass, which has grown on a gentle slope, just perfect to rest one's head on. Dear Phaedrus, what an excellent guide you are!

230d

Phaedrus: And you prove to be a wonderful and highly unusual person! Yes, from what you are saying, you really seem more like a visitor who is sightseeing than a native. In fact, you never go travelling like this outside our own borders, and I do not think you even go outside the walls at all.

Socrates: Forgive me, my excellent friend. For I am a lover of learning, and the rural haunts and the trees do not of themselves teach me anything, while the people in the city do. However, I think you have discovered the special potion for getting me out. For just as people lead hungry animals by waving a branch or piece of fruit, it turns out that you may also lead me about in this way through Attica, or anywhere else you please, by offering me scrolls of speeches. Well, now that we have arrived here, I think I shall lie down for the moment, and you should adopt any position you think easiest for reading, and then go ahead and read.

230e

Phaedrus: Well, listen.

231a

Phaedrus: “You know about my affairs, and you have heard how I think it best for us to arrange things, but I do not deserve to fail in my request just because I am not actually your lover, since, in the case of lovers, there is regret for any good they may have done once the desire comes to an end, but in the case of non-lovers, there is no occasion on which it is appropriate for them to change their minds. For they do good based upon their own capacity, not under compulsion but willingly, by deciding what is best for their own private interests. But lovers keep thinking about any harm done to their own interests on account

of love, and any good they themselves have done, and once they add any hardship they have sustained into the reckoning, they conclude that their loved ones have received all the favours they deserve a long time ago. But the non-lovers do not have to excuse the neglect of their own affairs on this account, or reckon up the trouble they have taken, or accept any blame for quarrels with relatives. Accordingly, since all such impediments are out of the way, nothing remains but to engage eagerly in actions which he thinks will please them.

231b

Phaedrus: “And yet it may be argued that lovers deserve great credit for this, since they claim to have the utmost affection for those whom they love, and they are prepared to favour their loved ones in word and in deed and be hated by others in the process. But if lovers are speaking the truth, it is easy to appreciate that anyone they love in the future will be more important to them than their present loved ones, and if the new ones so wish, they will even harm the old ones. Furthermore, how could it be reasonable to entrust this sort of thing to someone possessed of such an affliction as this, an affliction that no experienced person would ever attempt to prevent. And, indeed, they themselves accept that they are more sick than sound-minded, and that they realise that their thinking is disordered, but are unable to control themselves. So, once lovers return to their right mind, how could they regard as sound any decisions which were made under such circumstances? What is more, if you were to choose the best from amongst your lovers, your selection would be drawn from a small number, but if on the other hand you were to choose the most suitable from among all the others, you would be choosing from a greater number, where you would have much more hope of encountering someone worthy of your affections.

231e

Phaedrus: “Again, perhaps you are afraid of established convention, afraid that you will be found out by people and incur disgrace. Yet the likelihood is that lovers, believing that they are just as well regarded by others as they are by themselves, will feel an urge to speak out, and with an eye to their reputation proclaim to everyone that their efforts have not been for nothing. However, the non-lovers, as they are in control of themselves, are likely to choose the best course, rather than reputation in the eyes of their fellow men. But again, in the case of the lovers, most people must see or hear of them following their loved ones, and making quite a business of doing so. Consequently, whenever they are seen conversing with one another, it is assumed that they are getting together about a current or impending flirtation. But in the case of non-lovers, no one ever tries to criticise them because they get together, since they realise that it is necessary to talk to someone, either on account of friendship or some other enjoyment. What is more, suppose you became alarmed, thinking that it is difficult for a friendship to endure, and while a falling-out under other circumstances brings misfortune which is shared by both parties, the harm you suffer is enormous when you give away what is most important to you. In that situation it would be reasonable to be more afraid of your lovers, for their afflictions are many, and they think everything that happens is directed at harming them.

232c

Phaedrus: “On account of this, they also discourage the loved ones from meeting with other people, fearing those who have money in case they might surpass them in wealth, and fearing those who are educated in case they might prove superior in intelligence, and they are also wary of the power of anyone else who possesses any other advantage. Now, once they have persuaded you to incur the enmity of those people, the lovers leave you bereft of friends, and if you show more intelligence

than they do by looking to your own interest, you will find yourself at odds with them. Yet those who are not lovers but have attained what they wanted on account of excellence, would not be envious of these associates of yours. Instead, those who are not in love would detest those who refuse you, realising that you are being slighted by these fellows and benefited by your associates, and in consequence, they will have a much greater hope of friendship from the affair than enmity.

232e

Phaedrus: “What is more, most lovers develop a desire for the body first, before they have come to know your character or your other personal qualities, so that it is not clear whether they will still want to be friends with you once the passion has abated. Whereas, in the case of those who are not lovers but were friends with one another before all this took place, the friendship is not likely to be diminished by any of their pleasant experiences, but these are likely to be left as memorials for what is about to unfold. What is more, it better becomes you to be persuaded by me rather than by a lover, for those men praise your actions and utterances regardless of their merit, sometimes from a fear of being disliked, and also because their desire impairs their own judgement. Yes, this is the sort of behaviour that love exhibits. It makes those who are unfortunate regard anything which does not cause pain to others as an annoyance, while it compels those who are fortunate to praise pleasures that are unworthy of them. Consequently, it is much more appropriate to pity the loved ones than to envy them.

233b

Phaedrus: “However, if you trust in me, firstly I shall not associate with you to pander to the pleasure of the moment, but with an eye to your future advantage; not weakened by love, but master of myself; not resorting to bitter enmity over trifles, but slowly arousing a moderate anger over major issues. The

unintentional wrongs I forgive, the intentional ones I try to prevent, for these are the proofs of a friendship that will endure for a long time. But if you are still of the view that a strong friendship cannot arise unless the person is a lover, then you need to ponder that on this basis, we would not prize our sons very much, or our fathers or mothers, nor would we have acquired faithful friends who had become friends, not out of that sort of desire but through pursuits of a different nature.

233d

Phaedrus: “Again, if we ought to favour those who are most in need, then it is also appropriate in other situations to do good, not to the best, but to those who are most lacking, for they will be most grateful since they are relieved of the greatest misfortunes. What’s more, even in the case of private parties, it is not your friends who deserve to be invited, but beggars and those who need sustenance, for these people will be delighted with you, follow you and throng about your doors. They will be most pleased and most grateful and will pray that you may have many advantages.

233e

Phaedrus: “No, perhaps it is not appropriate to grant favours to those who are in greatest need, but those who can best return the favour; not to mere beggars, but those who deserve the attention; not to the sort who will just enjoy the benefit of your best years, but anyone who will share their own advantages with you when you have grown older; not to those who seek reputation in the eyes of others once they have achieved their objective, but anyone who will remain silent from a sense of shame in the eyes of all; not to those who will enjoy a short interval with you, but those who will be your friend in the same way throughout your entire life; not to someone who will seek an excuse for enmity once his desire abates, but those who will display their own excellence once you are past your prime.

234b

Phaedrus: “Now, keep in mind what I have told you and consider this point too. Friends give warnings to lovers about their debased way of life, but in the case of non-lovers, none of their acquaintances has ever censured them for poor judgement of their own affairs on that account. So, perhaps you may ask if I am exhorting you to gratify all non-lovers? But I do not think that even a lover would advise you to have the same attitude towards all lovers. For in that case, it would not merit the same gratitude from the recipient, nor could you keep it a secret from the others if you so wished. Whereas what is needed is that no harm at all should arise from this, and both parties should benefit.

234c

Phaedrus: “Now, I think I have said enough, but if you want more because you think I have left something out, just ask.”

Phaedrus: Well, how does the speech sound to you, Socrates? Isn't it extraordinary, especially in its use of language?

234d

Socrates: Yes, my friend, miraculous. It has astounded me! And I have had this experience because of you, Phaedrus, for I was watching you as you were reading and it seemed to me that you were made brighter by the speech. So, realising that you understand such matters better than I do, I followed you, and in the process I joined you in the wild frenzy, my divine friend.

Phaedrus: Come now, does it all sound like a joke?

Socrates: What? You think I am joking and not being serious?

Phaedrus: Not at all, Socrates, but by Zeus, the god of friendship, tell me the truth. Do you think there is anyone else in Greece who could deliver a more magnificent and expansive speech than this on the same topic?

234e

Socrates: What? Does the speech deserve praise from you, or from me, on the basis that the author has actually said what needed to be said, and not on the sole basis that each of the expressions he fashioned was clear, well rounded and precise? For if that is a requirement, I must concede the point to you, since on account of my nothingness I had overlooked this. I attended only to the rhetoric of the speech, and I do not think that even Lysias himself would regard that as satisfactory. And in fact, Phaedrus, although you may have a different view on this, I thought he made the same points twice or three times, as he was not really up to the task of saying a great deal on the same topic. Or perhaps he had no concern about a detail of that sort. And he appeared quite spirited to me, showing off that he could say the same thing in one way and then in another way, and say it superlatively on both occasions.

235b

Phaedrus: You are talking nonsense, Socrates, for this is the most significant feature of the speech. In fact, it omits nothing that is worth saying on the topic, so that nothing else can ever be said that is more expansive and more significant than what he has said.

Socrates: There I can agree with you no longer, for the wise men and women of old who have spoken and written on these matters will refute me if I give my assent just to gratify you.

Phaedrus: Who are these people? And where have you heard anything better than this?

235c

Socrates: Well, I cannot really say at the moment though I obviously heard it from someone ... perhaps from the lovely Sappho or the wise Anacreon or even from some prose writers.⁹ So, how do I come to this conclusion? My breast is somehow full, my wonderful friend, and I feel I could say something else besides what Lysias said and no worse. Now, because I recognise

my own ignorance, I am well aware that it was not from myself that I formed any of these notions. So, I think the only alternative is that I have been filled through my ears by streams flowing from elsewhere, as though I were a vessel. But again, on account of my dullness, I have actually forgotten how and from whom I heard this.

235e

Phaedrus: Very well, noblest of friends, you have expressed it perfectly. In fact, I will not even ask you to tell me from whom you heard this and how, as long as you do what you just said. Undertake to deliver a better speech than the one on the scroll, just as long and with different content, and I promise you that like the Nine Archons,¹⁰ I shall erect a life-sized golden image at Delphi, not just of myself but also of you.

Socrates: Phaedrus, you are very dear and truly golden if you think I am claiming that Lysias went completely awry, and I can say something entirely different. I do not think that would happen to even the most ordinary writer. For instance, in the case of this speech, do you think anyone asserting that the non-lover should be favoured more than the lover could avoid praising the prudence of the former and censuring the irrationality of the latter, and then have something else to say instead? No, these arguments are in a sense mandatory, and in such cases we should praise their construction and not their contrivance. However, in the case of arguments which are not mandatory and are difficult to contrive, we should praise the contrivance as well as their construction.

236b

Phaedrus: I am going along with your suggestion, for what you have said sounds reasonable to me. So, what I shall do is this. I shall allow you to propose that the lover is more sick than the non-lover and provided the rest of what you say is different, more expansive and more worthy than Lysias' speech, your

statue in beaten metal shall stand beside the offering of the Cypselids at Olympia.¹¹

Socrates: Phaedrus, you have taken the matter seriously because I attacked one of your favourites in jest. Do you actually think that I shall, in truth, attempt to make a different and more ornate speech, exceeding the wisdom of that man?

236c

Phaedrus: On this issue, my friend, you are in the same predicament that I was in. In fact, it is all the more necessary that you speak in any way you can so that we are not compelled to adopt the farcical exchanges of stage comedies. Take care you do not force me to come out with ‘Oh, Socrates! If I do not know Socrates then I have forgotten myself’ or, ‘he wanted to speak but gave himself airs’. No, you need to appreciate that we shall not be leaving this place until you speak all that you said you had ‘in your breast’. We are alone in an isolated spot and I am stronger and younger than you, so taking all of this into account ‘mark thou my words’¹² and do not opt to speak under compulsion when you can do it voluntarily.

236d

Socrates: Bless you, Phaedrus! But I shall be a laughing stock, extemporising as an amateur alongside a fine poet about the same topics.

Phaedrus: Do you appreciate the position you are in? Stop being coy with me! In fact, I have something to say that will pretty well force you to speak.

Socrates: Do not say it then!

236e

Phaedrus: Oh, but I shall say it! And my utterance will be an oath. In fact, I swear to you by... by what god... by this plane tree here if you like. I declare that if you do not deliver the speech here, in its very presence, I shall never perform another speech

for you or tell you about one either.

Socrates: Oh, you wretch! How well you have discovered what it is that compels a lover of discourse to do your bidding!

Phaedrus: Then why try to evade it?

Socrates: I can do so no longer now that you have sworn this. Indeed, how could I hold myself back from banquets of this sort?

237a

Phaedrus: Then speak!

Socrates: Well, do you know how I shall proceed?

Phaedrus: In what respect?

Socrates: I shall rush through the speech as quickly as possible, speaking with my head covered to avoid looking at you and losing my way out of sheer embarrassment.

Phaedrus: Just speak and arrange the other details as you please.

237b

Socrates: Come then, O ye clear-voiced Muses. Whether you are so described because of the nature of your song, or after the musical race of the clear-voiced Ligurians, join with me in this story which this excellent man here compels me to relate, so that his companion who seemed wise to him even before this, may now seem even wiser.

Socrates: Once upon a time there was a boy, more a youth really, very handsome too, and he had very many lovers. But one of them was wily, and although he was no less in love than the others, he had persuaded the boy that he did not love him. And on one occasion as he sought favour, he was persuading him of this very point, that one should favour the non-lover in preference to the lover. And so he said this: ^{237c} “Whatever the

issue, my boy, a single principle applies to those who intend to deliberate properly. They need to know what it is they are deliberating about, or else they must go entirely awry. However, most people are unaware of the fact that they do not know the essence of each thing. Therefore, on the basis that they already know, they come to no agreement at the outset of the enquiry and proceed to pay a predictable penalty. They agree with neither themselves nor one another. Now, you and I should avoid this shortcoming which we censure in others, and since the issue before us both is whether one should accord more friendship to the lover or to the non-lover, we should propose an agreed definition of love – what it is like and what power it possesses – and looking thereto and referring thereto, let us conduct our enquiry into whether love furnishes benefit or harm. Now, it is obvious to everyone, of course, that love is a desire, but we also know that even non-lovers desire the beautiful. On what basis then do we distinguish the lover from the non-lover? We need to recognise that there are two ruling and leading principles in each of us which we follow wherever they may lead: one is an inborn desire for pleasure, while the other is an acquired opinion which aims for the best. These two principles within us are sometimes in concord, but on occasion they are in conflict, and then, sometimes one, sometimes the other, is dominant. Now, when opinion that leads through reason to the best and is dominant, that dominion is called sound-mindedness, but when desire drags us irrationally towards pleasure, and is ruling in us, its rule is referred to as lust. And yet lust goes under many names, for it has many aspects and many parts, and whatever aspect happens to be most in evidence bestows its own name upon the possessor, a name that is neither admirable nor worth acquiring. So, when the desire associated with food dominates over the excellence of reason and over the other desires, gluttony will be in evidence, and its possessor will also be referred to by the same

name. And again, when its tyrannical control is related to drink, it is obvious what name we shall give to its possessor when it leads him in that direction. And in the case of other people of this sort, it is evidently appropriate to call them by the names of the appropriate desires, whichever one is in control at that time.

238b

Socrates: “Now, the type of desire which has prompted all that has been said is quite evident at this stage, but what is spoken is very much clearer than what is unspoken. So, once the desire devoid of reason has overpowered opinion conducive towards what is right, and has led towards delight in beauty, it too, for its part, is impelled forcefully towards bodily beauty by desires kindred to itself. Once this gains the ascendancy, it acquires a name derived from that very force and is called love.”

238c

Socrates: Well now, dear Phaedrus, does it seem to you, as it does to me, that I am undergoing some divine experience?

Phaedrus: Yes, certainly, Socrates, an extraordinary fluency has taken hold of you.

238d

Socrates: Hear me out in silence then. For this really seems to be such a divine place that you must not be surprised if I actually get caught by the Nymphs on occasion as I proceed with the speech. Yes, even at this stage I am almost enunciating verses of poetry.

Phaedrus: What you are saying is very true.

Socrates: And you are the one who is responsible for this! Anyway, listen to the rest of it, for the attack may perhaps be averted. However, these matters will be cared for by god; we for our part should return to our speech to the boy.

238e

Socrates: “There it is, my brave one! Now that the subject of our deliberations has been described and defined, what remains is to keep this in view, and state what benefit and what harm accrues to someone who favours a lover, and to someone who favours a non-lover. Now, it must be the case, I presume, that anyone who is ruled by desire and enslaved by pleasure will render a loved one as pleasing to himself as possible. Whatever offers no resistance is an utter delight to a sick man, whereas the equal or the stronger is detestable. So, the lover will not willingly tolerate either an equal or a stronger person as a favourite, and he will always make him weaker and inferior; and the fool is weaker than the wise man, the coward than the brave, the poor speaker than the orator, and a dull man is weaker than a clever one.

239a

Socrates: “When all these mental inadequacies, and more besides, develop in the loved one or are present by nature, the lover must be delighted. And if they are absent, he must contrive their presence or else forgo his momentary pleasure. Of course, the lover must be jealous and is a source of great harm through keeping the loved one away from numerous other associations which are advantageous and might make him a better man. And the greatest harm is done by barring him from an association whereby he might become most wise, namely divine philosophy. The lover must keep his favourite far away from this, as he is terrified of being held in contempt. And in other subjects, he must arrange that the loved one is completely ignorant and looks to the lover for everything, a state of affairs which would be delightful to the lover but very damaging to himself. Therefore, when it comes to the mental realm, a man in love is not useful at all either as a guardian or as a companion.

239c

Socrates: “As well as this, we also need to look to the condition of the body, and the nature and the extent of the care it will receive from someone who has gained control over it when that person is under compulsion to pursue pleasure in preference to good. Well, he will be seen pursuing someone who is feeble rather than tough, reared not in pure sunlight but beneath flickering shade, unaccustomed to manly exertions and harsh sweaty work, but quite used to a soft and unmanly way of life, adorned with extraneous colours and decorations because the natural qualities are absent. And he also engages in all the activities associated with such traits, but these are obvious and it is not worth continuing the list any further. Rather, we may proceed to another issue once we have summed this up in a single sentence. For such a feeble body, in war and in other circumstances where the need is great, gives courage to the enemy and strikes fear into friends and even lovers.

239e

Socrates: “So, let us accept that this is indeed obvious and proceed to formulate the next question. What benefit, or what harm, does the company and guardianship of a man in love afford us in relation to our property? Well, this much at least is evident to everyone and especially to the lover, that he would pray above all that the loved one be bereft of his dearest, most beneficent and most divine possessions. For the lover would welcome it were the loved-one to be deprived of father and mother, relatives and friends, believing them to be obstructive influences, critical of his delightful association with the loved one. But then, if the loved one has some property, gold or some other possession, he will regard him as not so easy to catch, and not so easy to manage once he has been caught. Accordingly, the lover really must begrudge his favourite any property he has acquired and be pleased if it is lost. What is more, the lover will pray that his favourite may be un-wed, childless and without a household for as long as possible, because he wants to

enjoy the sweetness for himself for as long as possible.

240b

Socrates: “Now, there are other depravities too, but in most cases, by some miracle, they are combined with a momentary pleasure, for instance, the flatterer is a dreadful monster who does a lot of harm, yet nature has commingled in him a certain delight which is not devoid of charm. A courtesan too may be censured as harmful, and so may a host of creatures with similar tendencies and behaviours in whom there is also pleasure, even though it is fleeting. But a lover, in addition to the harm he does, is the least pleasant person of all for loved ones to spend the day with. Yes, there is actually an old saying that ‘same age delights same age’, and I think it means that the equality of years leads to an equality of pleasure and produces friendship on account of this similarity. Yet even in these cases, they can get more than enough of one another’s company. Now, of course necessity is said, in general, to be a burden to everyone, and in addition to their dissimilarity, this principle is especially applicable to a lover and his favourite. For an older man consorting with a younger man does not willingly leave him day or night but is impelled by necessity and the sting of desire which draws the man on, affording him constant pleasures as he sees, hears, touches and is aware of the loved one through every sense so that he serves him diligently and delightedly.

240c

Socrates: “But what sort of consolation and what pleasure does the lover, for his part, grant to the loved one to ensure that the time they spend together does not end in utter disgust at beholding an aged face past its prime, and other features to match? For isn’t it the case that none of these are pleasant to hear described, but the constant unavoidable experience is even worse as he is watched over by a guardian who is suspicious of everyone and everything, and he hears inappropriate and exaggerated praise and criticism too, which are intolerable

when the man is sober, but embarrassing as well as intolerable when he has taken to drink and engages in unbridled and wearisome outspokenness?

240e

Socrates: “Now, when he is in love he is harmful and disgusting, but once the love abates he is untrustworthy thereafter to that very person whom he induced, with difficulty, to endure his tiresome company for that short time, a feat he accomplished by making numerous promises of future advantages, accompanied by countless oaths and imprecations.

241a

Socrates: “But when it is time to deliver on the promises, he has changed the ruler and leader within himself to reason and sound-mindedness, instead of love and madness. He has become a different person, but the loved one is unaware of this. So, as though he were talking to the same person, the loved one demands a favour from him, reminding him of what was done and what was said in the past. The lover, on the other hand, is ashamed and does not dare to say that he has become someone else, nor is he able to stand by the oaths and promises sworn under the former rule of unreason. At this stage, he has acquired reason and has become sound-minded in order to avoid becoming like that other person and being the same again by doing the same things he did before. He becomes a fugitive from all this, and he who was once a lover is compelled to betray his promises, and with the flipping of an oyster shell he turns and takes flight. And the loved one is compelled to pursue him, crying to heaven in anger having misunderstood the entire relationship from the outset. He should not, as it turns out, ever have favoured a man who is in love and perforce, unreasonable. No, far better to favour someone who is not in love and who is, therefore, reasonable. Otherwise, he would be compelled to place himself at the mercy of an unfaithful, awkward, jealous and disgusting person who is surely detrimental to his property,

detrimental also to his bodily well-being, but utterly detrimental to the development of his soul, and in truth there neither is nor shall there ever be anything more precious than this in the eyes of men or gods. So, you need to understand all of this, my boy, and appreciate that the affection of a lover is not accompanied by good intentions, but is a sort of hunger for food. Its aim is satisfaction, for ^{241d} As wolves have a liking for lambs So do lovers have affection for loved ones.”

^{241d}

Socrates: That is it, Phaedrus. You shall not hear me saying any more than this. Please let that be the end of the speech now.

Phaedrus: And yet, I thought this was half of the speech and you would say an equal amount about why the non-lover should be favoured to a greater extent, stating, in turn, all the advantages he affords. Why ever are you stopping at this stage, Socrates?

^{241e}

Socrates: Bless you. Do you not realise that I am already uttering epic verses, not just poetic verses, even though I am being critical? So, what do you think I shall come out with if I start to praise the other man? Surely you realise that I shall be undisguisedly inspired by the Nymphs to whom you have deliberately exposed me. So I should say, in short, that this other man has advantages which are the opposite of anything we have reviled in the first man. Yes, why do we need a long speech? In fact, enough has been said about both of them. And so on this basis, my story may suffer whatever fate it deserves to suffer, whilst I cross over this river and take myself away, before you force me into something even worse.

^{242a}

Phaedrus: Not yet, Socrates, not until the heat subsides anyway. Don't you see that it is almost mid-day and the sun is at its height? No, let us wait here while we discuss all that has been

said. We can go as soon as it cools down.

Socrates: Phaedrus, when it comes to speeches, you are divine and utterly amazing. In fact, I think that of all the speeches produced during your lifetime, no one has been responsible for producing more than you, either by delivering them yourself or somehow forcing someone else to do so. With the exception of Simmias,¹³ the Theban, you are far ahead of everyone else, and I think you have now become responsible once more for the delivery of a speech.

242b

Phaedrus: Well, that is good news anyway, but how did this happen, and what speech are you referring to?

Socrates: I was about to cross over the river, my friend, when the daimon came, the usual sign which comes to me, always holding me back from something I am about to do. And I seemed to hear a voice from there which would not allow me to depart until I had made atonement, because I have actually transgressed the divine. Now, although I am actually a seer, I am not a very significant one, but like undistinguished writers I am good enough for my own purposes, and therefore I now understand exactly what the transgression is. Yes, I tell you my friend, the soul too is prophetic, for something troubled me as I was delivering the speech just now, and I somehow felt ashamed that, in the words of Ibycus,¹⁴ 'I am sinning against the gods in return for reputation before men.' But I have now recognised my transgression.

242d

Phaedrus: Yes, but what do you mean?

Socrates: That was an awful speech you brought here, Phaedrus, and the one you made me deliver was awful too.

Phaedrus: How so?

Socrates: It was silly and just short of blasphemous. What could be more awful than that?

Phaedrus: Nothing, if what you say is true, that is.

242e

Socrates: What is this? Don't you believe that Love is the son of Aphrodite and a god?

Phaedrus: So they say, anyway.

Socrates: Not according to Lysias, or according to your speech, the one spoken out of my mouth once it had been bewitched by you. But if Love is, as indeed it is, a god or something divine, it could not be anything bad. Yet both these speeches about love have stated that it is bad, and so in this regard, they have committed a transgression concerning love. And what is more the silliness of the speeches was very clever, for without saying anything sound or true they made a solemn pretence of doing so, on the off chance that they might deceive some paltry specimens of humanity and win their esteem.

243a

Socrates: Therefore, my friend, it is necessary for me to be purified, and there is an ancient purification for those who have transgressed in storytelling, one that Homer was unaware of but was known to Stesichorus,¹⁵ for when he was deprived of his eyesight because he spoke ill of Helen, he did not, like Homer, fail to understand why. No, since he was a votary of the Muses, he understood the reason and immediately wrote: This story is not true, You never embarked on the well-benched ships Nor went to the citadel of Troy.¹⁶

243b

Socrates: And once he had completed the entire 'recantation', as it is called, his sight returned straightaway. Now, I shall, on this particular issue anyway, act more wisely than these poets. In fact, before anything happens because I spoke ill of Love, I

shall attempt to deliver a recantation to him with my head bare, and not covered out of shame, as it was before.

Phaedrus: Socrates, that is the most delightful thing you could have said to me.

243c

Socrates: And you also recognise, good Phaedrus, how shameless both speeches were, mine and the one you recited from the scroll. For suppose someone of a noble and gentle disposition should happen to hear us, someone in love with another person of a similar disposition or who had loved such a person once before. When we say that lovers arouse enormous enmity on account of trifles, and are jealous and malicious towards their favourites, won't he imagine that he is listening to people reared somehow among sailors, people who, when it comes to love, have beheld nothing free? Would he not be very far from agreeing with our criticisms of love?

Phaedrus: By Zeus, Socrates, he probably would.

243d

Socrates: Anyway, I am ashamed before this man and I am afraid of love itself, so I want to wash away the distasteful sound with the taste of a fresh speech. And I advise Lysias also to write, as soon as he can, that in similar circumstances the lover should be favoured more than the non-lover.

Phaedrus: Well, you may rest assured that this is what will happen, for once you have delivered your speech in praise of the lover it is absolutely inevitable that Lysias, under my compulsion, will write another in turn on the same topic.

Socrates: This I believe, as long as you are the person you are.

Phaedrus: Speak then with confidence!

Socrates: But where is my loved one, the boy I was talking to? He needs to hear this speech too, and if he does not hear it he

may go ahead and favour a non-lover.

Phaedrus: He is here, always close by your side whenever you want him.

244a

Socrates: Well then, my beautiful boy, you need to understand that the previous speech was from Phaedrus, the son of Pythocles from Myrrhinous, while the one I am about to deliver is from Stesichorus, the son of Euphemus from Himera. I must declare that: A story is not true if it states that one should bestow more favour on the non-lover when a lover is present, just because the one is mad and the other is sound-minded. For if it were simply the case that madness is bad, it would be acceptable to say this. However, enormous advantages now come to us through madness once it is given as a divine gift. In fact, the prophetess at Delphi and the priestesses at Dodona¹⁷ do a great deal of good for Greece, both privately and publicly, when they are mad, but they accomplish little or nothing when they are sound-minded. And if we were also to mention the Sibyl and those others who have recourse to inspired prophecy, foretelling many things to many people and correcting their ways for the future, we would be giving a lengthy description of what is obvious to everyone.

244b

Socrates: And yet, it is worth producing the evidence that those ancients who assigned the names did not regard madness as shameful or a matter of reproach, or else they would not have connected this particular word with the sublime skill that discerns the future by calling that skill manic. No, they realised that it was good, and gave it that name whenever it arises from divine providence. But people today, tastelessly inserting the letter T, have called it ‘mantic’. And when people in their right minds conduct their enquiry into the future through birds and other signs, which furnish human opinion with intelligence and

information on the basis of thought, the ancients called the skill 'oionoistic', but nowadays the moderns, being solemn with their long O sounds, call it 'oiōnistic'. And so, to this extent, the mantic is more perfect and venerable than the oiōnistic when name is compared to name and outcome is compared to outcome. And to this extent, the ancients bear witness to the superiority of madness from God over sound-mindedness originating among humans.

244d

Socrates: Then again, when diseases and the greatest afflictions occur in certain families, born of guilt from the distant past, madness has arisen, and exercising its prophetic power has found a means of release for those in need by resorting to prayers and services to the gods. From this, madness hits upon purifications and rites, rendering its possessor healthy, there and then and for all time, by finding a way out of the present evils for the person who is mad and possessed in the right way. A third madness and possession is from the Muses. This takes a tender and pure soul, arouses her and sends her into a frenzy of odes and other poetry, embellishes countless deeds of the ancient past, and educates future generations. But the man who arrives at the portals of poetry devoid of the Muses' madness, convinced that he may be a poet through competent technique, is himself incomplete and so is his poetry; and those works of a sound-minded man are set at nought by the poetry of the man who is mad.

245b

Socrates: Such are the beautiful achievements wrought by madness born of the gods, and I could relate even more to you, so let us have no fear on that account. Nor should any argument trouble us and make us afraid that we should prefer the sound-minded person as a friend rather than the moved one. No, this argument should triumph only if it proves that love is not sent by the gods as a boon both to the lover and the loved

one. But we, for our part, must prove the very opposite: that the madness of love is given by the gods to confer the greatest good fortune. And the proof will sound incredible to the clever folk but credible to the wise.

245c

Socrates: Now, we should first understand the truth about the nature of the soul, both human and divine, by looking to what happens to it and what it does. The beginning of the proof is as follows.

Socrates: All soul¹⁸ is immortal because the ever-moving is immortal, but that which moves another, and is moved by another, ceases living if it ceases moving. Indeed, only that which moves itself, since it does not depart from itself, never stops moving, and this is also the fount and source of motion for anything else that moves. But source is not generated, for everything that is generated must be generated from source, but it must not come from one. For if source were to be generated from something it would no longer be source. And since it is un-generated it must also be indestructible. For of course, once source is destroyed it will never be generated from something, nor will anything else be generated from it, since all things must be generated from source. Accordingly, whatever moves itself is the source of motion, and this can be neither generated nor destroyed, or else the entire heaven and all the earth would collapse into one and be static, without anything from which motion could ever be generated again. And since it has been shown that whatever is moved by itself is immortal, anyone who states that this is the very essence and definition of soul will not be put to shame. For every body to which movement comes from outside is soulless, but if the movement comes from within itself then that body is ensouled, because that is the nature of soul. But if it is the case that whatever moves itself is nothing other than soul, soul would, of necessity,

be both un-generated and immortal.

246a

Socrates: Well, that is enough about its immortality, but now we should say something about its form. To describe the kind of thing it is would require utterly divine powers and a lengthy exposition, but to say what it resembles would yield a shorter account befitting the powers of humans, so that is what we should present. Let it resemble the united power of a team of winged horses and their charioteer. Now, in the case of the gods, the horses and the charioteers are themselves all good and they come from good stock, but the teams belonging to others are a mixture. Now, our ruler, in the first place, has control of a pair of horses, and what is more, one of these horses is noble and good and such is his lineage too, while the other horse is of the opposite sort and of opposite lineage. So the control of our chariot is, of necessity, a difficult and troublesome task.

246b

Socrates: We should now try to explain how living beings have come to be called mortal and immortal. All soul cares for everything devoid of soul, and it traverses the entire heaven, coming into being in various forms at various times. When perfect and furnished with wings, it soars aloft and controls the entire universe. But once it has lost its wings it is borne along until it reaches something solid, and there it makes its abode, taking on an earthly body that seems to be self-moving on account of the power of the soul, and this combination is called a living being, a body and soul conjoined, and it is given the designation of mortal. It is not immortal on the basis of a single reasoned argument; however, without seeing or properly understanding God, we do imagine some living creature possessing a soul and possessing a body which are conjoined for all time. Well, let these matters be arranged and described in whatever manner is pleasing to God, and let us understand

instead the reason for the loss of the wings. Why does the soul lose them? The answer is something like this: ^{246d} The power of the wing naturally draws that which is weighty upwards, raising it aloft to where the race of the gods dwells, and the wing somehow has more communion with the divine than anything else associated with the body. Now, the divine is noble, wise, good and everything of that sort, so the wing of the soul is nourished most by these and it grows, but it is withered and destroyed by the opposite qualities such as deformity and baseness. Now, Zeus, the supreme ruler in heaven, driving a winged chariot, is first to go forth, bringing order to all and caring for all, while the army of gods and daimons follows him arranged in eleven bands. For Hestia alone remains in the dwelling place of the gods, but the others, who are counted among the twelve gods, assume command and lead their cohort based upon the rank assigned to each.

^{247a}

Socrates: Now, many and blessed are the sights and the pathways within heaven, and the well-favoured race of gods makes its course through these, each of the gods doing what belongs to himself, while anyone who wishes and is able to do so follows after, for envy stands outside the heavenly choir. But when they go to a feast or a banquet, they proceed to the summit of the vault above the heavens and the way is steep. And yet the evenly balanced chariots of the gods, obedient to the rein, make their way easily. But for the others it is difficult. For the horse with bad tendencies weighs them down, because it is heavy and inclined to sink to the ground unless it has been well trained by the charioteers. Here indeed lies pain and struggle for the soul. For whenever the souls that are called immortal attain the summit, they proceed outside and stand at the back of the heaven, and once they stand there, the revolution carries them around and they contemplate the sights outside of the heaven.

247c

Socrates: But none of the poets of this world has ever yet sung the praises of the region beyond the heaven, nor will they ever sing them in a worthy manner. But we must dare to speak the truth anyway, especially when truth is our theme. So this is how it is: this region contains the colourless, utterly formless, intangible being that actually is, with which the realm of true knowledge is concerned, seen only by reason, the pilot of the soul. Now, since the mind of a god is nourished by reason and unmixed knowledge, so too is every soul that cares to receive what is proper to it. Eventually, beholding what is, the soul is delighted, and contemplating the truth, it is nourished and gladdened, until the revolution carries it around in a circle to the same place. In the revolution, soul has sight of justice itself, sound-mindedness and knowledge; not knowledge to which becoming is added, this is knowledge different under different circumstances, concerned with what we normally call ‘things that are’; no, it is the knowledge of that which really is. And once the soul has, in like manner, contemplated and feasted upon the other things that really are, it descends once more into the inner heaven and goes home. And when soul arrives there, its charioteer stations the horses at the feeding stall, sets ambrosia before them and gives them nectar to drink.

248a

Socrates: Such is the life of the gods. But the other souls, that best follow and resemble a god, raise up the head of their charioteer into the outer region and are borne around with the revolution, troubled by the horses and barely having sight of the things that are. Others ascend sometimes but descend at other times, and being impelled by the horses they see some things and fail to see others. And yet all of the other souls follow out of a yearning for the upper region, but they are unable to attain it, and are borne along beneath the surface, knocking against one another and trampling one another as each tries to

get ahead of the other. This results in tribulation, conflict and perspiration in which many souls are maimed due to poor charioteering, and many wings are badly broken. But after much exertion, failing in their vision of what is, they depart, and once they leave they feed upon opinion.

248c

Socrates: The reason for the great eagerness to behold the plain of truth is that the nutriment appropriate to the best part of soul lies on the meadow there, and the nature of the wing which lifts the soul upwards is nourished by this. And the ordinance of necessity is as follows: any soul that has become a companion to a god and has sight of any of the truths is safe until the next revolution, and if the soul can do this continually, it is always preserved from harm. But whenever it does not see, because it cannot keep up, and is filled with forgetfulness and vice and weighed down through some mischance and sheds its wings on account of the heaviness and falls to the ground, the law decrees that the soul be not implanted in any beastly nature at its first birth. Rather, the soul that has seen most is implanted in the seed of a man who will become a philosopher¹⁹ or a lover of beauty or a musical and loving person. Those in the second rank enter into lawful kings or military and sovereign natures, the third into political and administrative or financially oriented types, the fourth into a lover of hard exercise or someone who will be concerned with bodily healing, the fifth will have the life of a prophet or someone involved with mystic rites, the sixth will be suited to the poetic life or one that involves some other imitative activity, the seventh to that of a craftsman or farmer, the eighth to that of a sophist or demagogue, and the ninth to that of a tyrant.

248e

Socrates: Now, in all these cases, whoever has behaved justly obtains a better destiny, while whoever behaves unjustly obtains a worse. For the soul does not ever arrive back at the

same place it came from for ten thousand years, because it does not become winged until that time has elapsed, unless it is the soul of one who has genuinely loved wisdom or combined his love of boys with a love of wisdom. These souls become winged in the third cycle of a thousand years if they have chosen this life thrice in succession, and in the three thousandth year they depart. As for the others, once they have completed their first life they encounter judgement, and having been judged, some go to places of correction beneath the earth where they pay the full penalty while others are borne aloft by justice to some place in the heaven and spend their time as they deserve based on how they lived their life when in a human form. But in the thousandth year both arrive for allocation and choice of the second life, and they choose the one they want. At this stage a human soul takes on the life of a beast, and from a beast someone who was once a human enters a human being again. Indeed, a soul that has never beheld the truth will not attain the human condition. For a human being must understand what is said on the basis of form, proceeding from many perceptions to one inferred through reasoning. And this is recollection of those things our soul knew when it accompanied the god, and with a downward glance on things that are now said to be, lifted its gaze to what actually is. Therefore, it is right indeed that only the mind of the philosopher be winged, for by the power of memory it is always as close as it can be to those things by whose proximity a god is divine. And, indeed, someone with proper recourse to such reminders, being continually initiated into perfect mysteries, is the only one who actually becomes perfect. And standing apart from the preoccupations of humanity and getting close to the divine, the person is criticised by the multitude for being disturbed, but the multitude overlooks the fact that he is divinely inspired.

249d

Socrates: Now, this is what our entire discourse concludes about the fourth kind of madness. Whenever someone sees some beauty in this world, and being reminded of the true beauty becomes winged and flutters eagerly to fly aloft but cannot do so, he gazes upwards like a bird, heedless of what is below, and this is the reason he is regarded as mad. So, this is itself the best of all the forms of divine possession, and its origin is the best. It is best for the possessor and for someone who comes to share in it, and when partaking of this madness the man who loves what is beautiful is called a lover. For as we said, every soul of man has, in the course of nature, contemplated things that are, or else it would not have entered into this human form. But it is not easy for every soul to remember those former visions based on what they see here. Perhaps at that time they saw the things there only briefly or met misfortune when they fell down here and being turned toward injustice by bad company forgot the sacred visions they once saw. Few souls indeed remain in whom there is adequate memory, but when these behold any likenesses of the things that are there, they are astounded and can no longer contain themselves, but they do not understand what the experience is because their awareness is inadequate. Now, there is no splendour in the present likenesses of justice, sound-mindedness and everything else that souls revere. But just a few, having recourse to their resemblances, contemplate the form they actually resemble with difficulty through organs that are dull.

250b

Socrates: However, beauty was there to be seen at that time, shining brightly, when in company with a blissful cohort the souls saw a blessed vision and contemplated it, we ourselves following Zeus, others following some other god. We were initiated into what it is proper to call the most blessed of the mysteries which we celebrated, perfect in ourselves, and unaffected by those evils that lay in wait for us thereafter. Being

initiated into perfect, simple, unmoved and blissful revelations, we stood as initiates in a pure light, and we were pure and not entombed in this so-called body that we carry around with us, imprisoned like an oyster in its shell.

250c

Socrates: Now, let these be our tributes to memory, for whose sake I have just spoken at such length, yearning for what was once seen. But as for beauty, as we have just said, it was there with those others and it was shining, and when we arrived here we apprehended it through the clearest of our senses as it glistened in its clarity. Indeed, sight is the keenest of the perceptions furnished to us through the body. Wisdom is not seen, for it would arouse formidable loves if anything of this sort were to present a clear image of itself to the eye, and the same goes for other objects of love. But this role now belongs to beauty alone, and accordingly it is most resplendent and most beloved.

250e

Socrates: Now, someone who is not a new initiate, or who has been corrupted, is not transported readily from here to there towards beauty itself when he sees something here that bears its name. And so he does not look upon it with reverence, but gives himself over to pleasure and tries to behave like a four-legged animal and beget offspring, and keeping close company with wantonness, he is not afraid or ashamed to pursue pleasure contrary to nature. But when a recent initiate, who had seen a great deal at the time, beholds a god-like face or bodily form which imitates beauty well, he shudders at first and some of the former fears come over him. Then he looks upon it as a god and becomes reverential, and if he was not afraid of a reputation for utter madness he would offer sacrifices to his favourites as if to a statue and a god. Once he has seen him, the shuddering gives way as usual, and he is seized by perspiration and unaccustomed warmth, for he is warmed when he receives

the outpouring of beauty through his eyes, an outpouring by which the nature of the wing is nourished. The areas from which it grows are melted by the warmth, regions that have been closed over for some time by this hardness and prevented from growing anew, and with the influx of nutriment the shaft of the wing swells and surges forth in growth beneath the whole form of the soul, for the entire soul was winged at one time. As this goes on it boils and throbs all over, and the experience is like that of children when they first grow teeth and an irritation and pain arise in the gums. The same thing happens to the soul that begins to grow wings; it seethes and is pained and tickled as it grows its wings. Whenever the soul looks to the beauty of the boy, it receives portions that emanate and flow from there, and for this reason we give them the name 'longing'.²⁰ Receiving these, the soul has respite from its pain and rejoices, but when it gets separated and becomes arid, the openings of the channels from which the wings shoot dry up and close, blocking the new growth of the wing. This is trapped inside along with the desire, throbbing like a blood vessel, each stinging at its own particular exit channel, so that the soul is stung all over and is maddened and pained. However, once soul has further memory of the beautiful one it rejoices. Because the pain and the rejoicing are mixed, the soul is dismayed by the strangeness of the experience, and being frustrated to the point of fury, is unable in its madness either to sleep by night or remain still by day, but it runs to wherever it thinks it may behold the possessor of the beauty it longs for. Once the soul sees him and allows the desire to pour over it, it releases what was previously closed in. It secures a respite, its stings and pains cease, and for that moment the soul enjoys once more that sweetest pleasure. Now, soul does not give this up willingly, nor does it set anyone above the beautiful one. No, forgetting mother, brothers and all her companions it thinks nothing of losing its substance through neglect, and despising the standards and decorum on which it

previously prided itself, soul is ready to act as a slave and lie down wherever anyone allows it closest to the one it yearns for. Indeed, as well as revering the possessor of beauty, the soul also finds that he is the only healer of her intense suffering.

252b

Socrates: So, fair boy, the recipient of my discourse, this is the condition that humanity refers to as love, but when you hear what the gods call it you will probably laugh because of your extreme youth. But I believe that some experts on Homer quote two lines about love from his secret works, the second of which is quite outrageous and not particularly metrical. What they recite is this: All the mortals call him winged Erōs But because he must grow wings the immortals call him Pteros.

252c

Socrates: Well, you may be persuaded by these lines or you may not, but in any case the cause and the actual experience of those in love is as I have described.

Socrates: Now, any follower of Zeus who has been taken by love is able to bear the burden of the winged one with equanimity, while those who attend upon Ares and have traversed the circuit along with him, once they have been captured by love and think they have suffered some injustice at the hand of their loved one, become murderers, and are quite prepared to sacrifice themselves and their favourites. And each person lives in this way, revering and imitating as best he can the particular god in whose cohort he follows, as long as he remains uncorrupted and is living out his first life here; and in this manner he interacts and behaves towards his loved ones or anyone else.

252d

Socrates: Each person selects his love from among the beautiful ones based upon character and behaving as if the loved one is himself a god. Each constructs a kind of statue for himself and

adorns it as an object of reverence and worship. Those from the cohort of Zeus seek out in their loved ones a soul that resembles Zeus, so they look for someone who is by nature both philosopher and leader. And once they find him and have come to love him, they do all they can to turn him into a person of that kind. Now, if they have not embarked upon the practice before, then they attempt to learn at this stage from any source they can, and they search themselves, and following the traces within themselves they find that they are well equipped to discover the nature of their own god on account of their intense compulsion to look towards that god. And reaching out to him by means of memory, they are inspired, and adopt his habits and activities in so far as it is possible for a human to partake of the divine. And of course, believing the loved one is responsible for all this, they become even more affectionate, and if they draw upon the well-springs of Zeus, as the Bacchants do,²¹ they pour the waters forth again over the soul of their loved one, making him as like unto their own god as possible.

253b

Socrates: Those who for their part follow Hera seek the regal sort, and once they find him they do all the same things to him. And the followers of Apollo and each of the gods, proceeding in the same way with reference to their god, seek a similar nature in their own favourite. When they gain possession of him, they themselves imitate the god, and they also persuade and discipline their favourites, leading them into the behaviour and character of that god, each according to ability without recourse to envy or petty resentment towards their favourites. Rather, they act as they do in an effort to bring the loved one into complete and comprehensive resemblance to themselves and the god whom they revere. Now, the eagerness of those who truly love, and the consummation thereof, becomes noble and blessed provided they attain what they desire in the manner I describe, through an affection of one for the other

born of the madness of love, once the loved one has been captured. Now, the manner of his capture is as follows.

253c

Socrates: At the beginning of this story we divided each soul in three: two elements were like horses and the third like a charioteer. Let us allow these comparisons to stand. However, although one of the horses is good and the other is not, we have not described the excellence of the good one or the vice of the bad one, so we should explain this now. Well, the horse standing in the better position has an upright aspect. He is clean-limbed, stately, with aquiline features, white in colour, with black eyes, a lover of honour conjoined with sound-mindedness and modesty, and a companion of true reputation. He has no need of the whip for he is controlled by the word of spoken command alone. But the other one is misshapen, gross, put together at random, with a powerful short neck, a flat face, black in colour, grey and bloodshot eyes, a companion of wantonness and pretension, woolly about the ears, deaf, reluctantly yielding to whip and spur combined.

253e

Socrates: Now, whenever the charioteer beholds the vision that awakens love, the entire soul is warmed through the sense and is filled with tickling and the stings of yearning. The horse that is obedient to the charioteer is restrained by reverence at that moment as always, and it holds itself back from leaping upon the loved one, while the other one no longer heeds the whip or spur of the charioteer, but moves with a powerful leap, and causing enormous difficulties to the other horse and to the charioteer, it forces them to approach their favourites and make mention of the delight of amorous pursuits. The other two offer resistance initially, troubled at being forced into dreadful and unlawful acts. But in the end, when there is no limit to the affliction, they go along with him, give up and consent to do as they are bidden. And once they get close to him, they also

behold the gleaming face of the loved one. When the charioteer sees this, his memory is transported to the nature of the beautiful, and he beholds it once more, seated alongside sound-mindedness, upon a sacred throne. At the sight of this, being filled with awe and reverence, he falls backwards, and with this he is forced to pull back upon the reins so strongly that both horses end up seated on their haunches. One is willing, as he offers no resistance, but the wanton horse is extremely unwilling. When they are further away, one horse, on account of his modesty and amazement, drenches the entire soul with perspiration, while the other, once he recovers from the pain he incurred from the bit and from his fall, gradually recovers his breath and engages in angry abuse, greatly reviling the charioteer and his companion horse for their cowardice and weakness in abandoning their position and their agreement. And he impels them forward once more against their will, and he agrees only reluctantly to their pleading to defer this to another occasion. But when the arranged time comes, they pretend to forget, but he reminds them. He becomes violent, neighing and pulling, he compels them to approach the favourite once more with the same propositions. And once they get close, he puts his head down and stretches out his tail, bites into the bit, and drags them forward with no shame at all. But the charioteer undergoes the same experience as before, with even greater intensity. He falls back like a runner from a starting rope, wrenching the bit back from the teeth of the wanton horse with an even greater force. Bloodying his foul-speaking tongue and jaws, and pinning his legs and haunches to the ground, he inflicts pain. Once the evildoer has suffered this a number of times, he gives up his wantonness, he is humbled, and at that stage he follows the providence of the charioteer, and whenever he beholds the beautiful one he is overpowered by fear. And as a consequence, the soul of the lover follows its favourite thereafter in reverence and awe.

255a

Socrates: Now, as the loved one is served as the equal of a god, receiving total service from a lover who is no pretender but has experienced true love, the loved one is naturally the friend of the one who serves him. And even if, perchance, he has been misled by his schoolmates, or anyone else who says that it is disgraceful to associate with a lover, and he rejects the lover on that account, eventually, in the course of time, age and fate lead him to admit the lover into his company. For it is decreed that bad can never be friend to bad nor can good avoid being friend to good. But once he allows him in and accepts his conversation and company, the goodwill emanating from the lover astonishes the loved one as he becomes aware that not even all his other friends and associates combined furnish a single portion of friendship to compare with this god-inspired friend.

255b

Socrates: But if this arrangement goes on for some time and there is close contact in the gymnasium and other meeting places, then at last, the spring of that stream which Zeus called longing when he was in love with Ganymede,²² is borne copiously towards the lover and some of it sinks into him, while the rest flows without, once he has been filled to overflowing. And like breath or an echo rebounding from a smooth hard surface and carried once more to the place from which it issued forth, so too does the stream of beauty travel back to the beautiful one through the eyes, the natural way to go into the soul. Arriving there, it excites the soul, moistens the openings for the wings, stimulates their growth, and also fills the soul of the loved one in turn with love. Now, he loves, but he is puzzled as to what he loves; neither does he know what he is experiencing nor is he able to express it. Like someone who has caught an eye disease from another person, he is unable to explain its cause. He sees himself in the lover just as if he were looking in a mirror, but he is unaware of this. And whenever his

lover is present he has relief from his pain, and so too does the lover for the same reasons. But whenever he is absent, for those same reasons again, he yearns and he is yearned for. In the returned love he possesses an image of love, but he does not call it love because he thinks it is not love but friendship. His desires are like those of the lover but they are weaker; to see, touch, kiss and to lie down with him and, indeed, in all likelihood, this happens very soon afterwards.

255e

Socrates: Now, as they lie together the uncontrolled horse of the lover has something to say to the charioteer, and he claims some small recompense in return for his numerous afflictions. But in the case of the loved one this horse has nothing to say, but swollen with desire and in some confusion, he embraces and kisses the lover as though he were welcoming an extremely well-intentioned man, and when they are lying together, he is unable to refuse his own part in gratifying the man in love, if he should ask for anything. But his companion horse, for its part, along with the charioteer resists these tendencies with modesty and with reason. Now, if the very best part of mind, the part that leads to an ordered life and to philosophy, is victorious, they live their life here in blessedness and concord, masters of themselves and orderly, enslaving whatever produces degeneracy in the soul and granting freedom to whatever renders it excellent. And when they die, they are winged and light, having won a victory in one of three bouts in the true Olympic games, and neither human sound-mindedness nor divine madness can confer a greater good upon a man than this.

256c

Socrates: However, if they resort to a coarser life, loving honour and not wisdom, then perhaps when drunk or in some careless moment, the uncontrolled horses in them both, catching the souls off their guard, draw them together, make that choice which most people call blessed, and obtain what

they desire. Once this has happened they continue the practice thereafter, but sparingly, because their activity has not been accepted by the entire mind. And so, to a lesser extent than the others, they live their lives as friends to one another, throughout their love and also when they have gone beyond it, for they believe they have given and received enormous assurances from one another which it is not lawful to forsake by ever becoming enemies. When their lives end, they are unwinged, but they depart from the body eager to grow wings, so they derive no small recompense from their madness born of love. For it is not ordained that those who have already commenced their journey beneath the heavens should yet enter into darkness or journey beneath the earth. Instead, they live a bright life journeying with one another in blessedness, and on account of their love their plumage is alike when they become winged.

256e

Socrates: These, my boy, are the blessings great and divine that the friendship of a lover will bestow upon you, while the familiarity of the non-lover is adulterated with a mortal sound-mindedness and what it dispenses is mean and mortal. Engendering in the friendly soul a slavishness that most people praise as a virtue, the non-lover condemns her to roll about the earth and beneath the earth, mindlessly, for nine thousand years.

257a

Socrates: This recantation, O beloved Eros, is bestowed upon you. It is the finest and most excellent my ability can offer, especially in its use of some poetic language, under compulsion from Phaedrus. Forgive what was said previously and look upon these words with favour. Be kind and gentle, and do not take away the skill in love that you have bestowed upon me, and do not, in your anger, impair it. And grant me, even more than now, to be revered in the eyes of the fair. If Phaedrus and I said

anything offensive to you earlier, blame Lysias, the father of the argument. Bar him from speeches of this sort and turn him to philosophy, just as his brother Polemarchus has turned, so that this lover of his may no longer be pulled in two directions as he is now but may simply direct his life towards love accompanied by philosophical discourse.

257c

Phaedrus: I join you in prayer, Socrates. If this is what is best for us then may it be so. But I have been amazed for some time at how much more beautifully you crafted this speech than the previous one. So, I am hesitant in case Lysias may look ordinary if he actually consents to present another speech to rival it. Indeed, my wonderful friend, some politician was abusing him recently and he criticised Lysias on this point, and throughout the abuse he kept calling him a ‘speechwriter’. So, perhaps we may find that he gives up writing out of concern for his reputation.

257d

Socrates: Young man, the opinion you are expressing is laughable, and you are quite wrong about your friend if you think he is as timid as that. But perhaps you believe that the man who was abusing him meant this as a reproach.

Phaedrus: Well, that is how it seemed, Socrates. And I presume you yourself are aware that the most powerful and important people in the city are ashamed to write speeches and leave behind their own written compositions. They are fearful of their reputation thereafter, and the possibility that they might be called sophists.

257e

Socrates: You are unaware, Phaedrus, that the sweet elbow gets its name from the long elbow of the Nile, and as well as the elbow, you do not appreciate that the most self-important politicians are the ones who most love speech writing and

leaving behind written records. At any rate, whenever they write a speech, they are so delighted by those who approve of it that they write the names of these admirers into the beginning of the speech.

Phaedrus: What do you mean by this? I do not understand.

258a

Socrates: Don't you understand that in the writings of politicians the name of the approver is written first?

Phaedrus: In what way?

Socrates: For instance, the politician writes, 'It was resolved by the Council' or 'by the people' or both, and says, 'He declared' referring of course to himself in a very solemn manner and praising himself. After this he speaks, showing off his own wisdom to his approvers, sometimes producing a very lengthy composition. Isn't this sort of thing a composed speech? Does it seem otherwise to you?

258b

Phaedrus: Not to me.

Socrates: Now, if the speech enters the records, the composer leaves the place of assembly in delight. But if it is left out of the records, and he does not enter the ranks of speechwriters, and his words are not worth writing down, both he himself and his companions go into mourning.

Phaedrus: Very much so.

258c

Socrates: Obviously, because they regard this activity as a thing of wonder which they do not hold in contempt.

Phaedrus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: What about this? Once he becomes such a competent orator or king that he acquires the power of a Lycurgus, a Solon, or a Darius,²³ becomes immortal as a speechwriter in the eyes of

the city, won't he believe that he himself, whilst still living, has become the equal of a god? And won't succeeding generations think the same thing about him on seeing his compositions?

Phaedrus: Very much so.

258d

Socrates: Now, do you believe that anyone of that sort, whoever he is or however negative his attitude to Lysias, would criticise him just because he composes speeches?

Phaedrus: Well, that is unlikely, at least on the basis of what you have just said, for in that case, it seems, he would be criticising his own heart's desire.

Socrates: So, it is obvious to everyone that speech writing is not shameful, not in itself anyway.

Phaedrus: How could it be?

Socrates: But I believe that the disgrace lies not in speaking or writing properly, but shamefully and badly.

Phaedrus: Obviously.

Socrates: So, what approach leads us to write properly, and what approach leads to its opposite? Do we need to test Lysias on these issues, or anyone else who has ever written or will write a political or personal composition, whether in verse like a poet or in prose like an ordinary person?

258e

Phaedrus: Are you really asking if we need to test them? What else is there to live for, I might ask, if not for the sake of pleasures of this sort? Surely not for the sake of pleasures that must be preceded by pain if they are to be enjoyed, a feature of most pleasures associated with the body. And so they are rightly referred to as slavish.

Socrates: Well, it seems we have plenty of free time. And I think that the cicadas above our heads are looking down upon us as they sing and converse with one another in the heat. Now, if they were also to see the two of us, like most people at midday, not conversing but slumbering, enchanted by them due to our mental lethargy, they would quite rightly laugh at us and regard us as slaves who had arrived at their abode to spend the afternoon asleep, like sheep around a spring. But if they see us conversing and sailing past them as if they were Sirens and we were immune to their charms, perhaps they would be pleased, and grant us that special gift they have from the gods for bestowal upon humanity.

259b

Phaedrus: But what is it they possess? Apparently I have not heard of it.

Socrates: Well, it is most inappropriate for someone who loves the Muses not to have heard of such matters. Anyway, it is said that these creatures were once humans in the ages before the Muses existed, and when the Muses came into being and song was made manifest, some people of that age were actually so stricken with pleasure that they neglected eating and drinking in favour of singing and did not even notice that they had died. After that, the race of cicadas sprang forth from them, having acquired a gift from the Muses, which meant they were born with no need for nutriment, but they immediately start singing, without either eating or drinking, until the day they die. Afterwards, they go to the Muses to report who in this realm pays respect to each one of them. And so they tell Terpsichore of those who have honoured her in dance, and they render them more agreeable to her, and they tell Erato of those who honour her in matters of love, and they report to the other Muses in a similar fashion based upon the kind of honour that belongs to each. But to Calliope, the eldest, and to Ourania, next

in age, they tell of those who spend their lives in philosophy and honour the music of these two Muses who are most associated with the heaven and with discourse, both human and divine, and send forth the most beautiful sound. So, there are very many reasons why we should converse in the middle of the day rather than sleep.

259d

Phaedrus: Yes, indeed, we should converse.

259e

Socrates: Well then, a moment ago we proposed to consider the manner in which a speech may be properly spoken or written, or badly spoken or written, so let us consider this.

Phaedrus: Of course.

Socrates: Now, for anything to be spoken properly and well, mustn't the mind of the speaker know the truth about the matters on which they intend to speak?

260a

Phaedrus: What I have heard on this question, dear Socrates, is that someone who intends to be an orator need not understand what is actually just, but only what will seem so to the majority of those who will pass judgement, and need not understand what is truly good, but only what will seem so. For persuasion arises from these seemings and not from the truth.

Socrates: Whatever the wise may say, Phaedrus, 'must not be cast aside'.²⁴ Instead we should ask ourselves if they are right, and this statement in particular should not be dismissed.

Phaedrus: What you say is correct.

Socrates: Let us consider it then.

Phaedrus: In what way?

260b

Socrates: If I were to persuade you to acquire a horse to repel our enemies, and we were both ignorant about horses, but I did happen to know this much about you: that Phaedrus believes that a horse is ‘the tame animal with the largest ears...’

Phaedrus: That would be ridiculous, Socrates!

Socrates: Not yet! But it would be ridiculous if I were so eager to persuade you that I composed a speech in praise of the donkey, calling it a horse and saying that the beast is well worth acquiring for domestic and military purposes, useful both for fighting and for its ability to carry equipment, and beneficial in many other ways.

260c

Phaedrus: Then it would be utterly ridiculous.

Socrates: Now, isn’t it better to be ridiculous and friendly, rather than clever and hostile?

Phaedrus: So it appears.

Socrates: Well, suppose an orator, who is ignorant of good and evil, takes hold of a city in a similar state of ignorance, and persuades the people not by praising some silly donkey as if it were a horse, but by praising evil as if it were good. And suppose this orator studies the opinions of the multitude, and persuades them to do evil rather than good, what sort of harvest do you think this rhetoric will reap thereafter from the seeds it has sown?

260d

Phaedrus: It will not be very good.

Socrates: Now, my good man, have we been reviling this skill in speaking more crudely than we should? Perhaps it might respond, ‘Strange people, why on earth are you talking such nonsense? Indeed, I do not compel anyone to learn how to speak in ignorance of the truth. No, if my advice counts for

anything, they should acquire truth first and then have recourse to me. In fact, my proud boast is that without me, someone who knows things that are will not have the skill to persuade anyone else.'

260e

Phaedrus: And would the skill be right to say all this?

Socrates: I think it would, provided the arguments that are descending upon it bear witness to the fact that it is a skill. For I seem, somehow, to hear some arguments approaching and testifying that it is lying, and that it is not a skill but an unskilled trick. And a Spartan is declaring that there is not, nor shall there ever be, a real skill in speaking unless there is contact with truth.

261a

Phaedrus: These are necessary arguments, Socrates. Bring them here and let us scrutinise what they are saying and how.

Socrates: Come hither then, you noble creatures, and persuade Phaedrus, this begetter of fair offspring, that unless he engages properly in philosophy, he will never be able to speak properly about anything. So, let Phaedrus answer your questions.

Phaedrus: Just ask.

Socrates: Well then, wouldn't rhetoric as a whole be a skill which leads the soul through words, not only in law courts and any other public meetings, but also in private? Isn't it the same skill whether it involves minor or major issues and, strictly speaking, deserving of no more respect when dealing with important matters rather than trivial ones? Is this what you have heard?

261b

Phaedrus: No, by Zeus, it's not as extensive as that! Rather, the skill in speaking and writing mainly applies to lawsuits and also to delivering public orations. I have not heard of this wider

application.

Socrates: What? Have you only heard the systems of rhetoric that Nestor and Odysseus composed in their spare time at Troy and have you not heard those of Palamedes?²⁵

Phaedrus: No, by Zeus, nor those of Nestor either, unless you are turning Gorgias into Nestor, and Thrasymachus and Theodorus into Odysseus.²⁶

261c

Socrates: Perhaps. Anyway, let's leave these fellows aside. You should state what legal disputants engage in, in courts of law. Do they not contradict one another? Or what shall we say?

Phaedrus: Exactly that.

Socrates: About what is just and what is unjust?

Phaedrus: Yes.

Socrates: Won't someone who does this by means of a skill make the same thing appear just at one moment and, if the person wishes, unjust the next moment to the very same people?

Phaedrus: Of course.

Socrates: And when engaged in public speaking that person will make the same thing seem good to the populace at one moment and the very opposite the next?

Phaedrus: Just so.

261d

Socrates: And we know, don't we, that the Eleatic Palamedes²⁷ speaks with a skill that makes the same things appear to those listening as like and unlike, one and many, at rest and in motion?

Phaedrus: Very much so.

Socrates: So, verbal contradiction is not associated only with law courts and public speaking but apparently, if it is actually a skill, it is a single skill associated with all verbal utterances. By means of this skill, someone will be able to make anything that is capable of resembling anything else resemble that which it is capable of resembling and bring to light any other resemblance that has been hidden.

Phaedrus: What sort of activity are you describing?

261e

Socrates: I think it will become clearer if we investigate it as follows: does deception arise when there are many differences or just a few?

262a

Phaedrus: When there are few.

Socrates: Then again, if you proceed in small steps rather than large ones, your transition to the opposite will be less noticeable.

Phaedrus: Inevitably.

Socrates: In that case, someone who intends to deceive another, without being deceived by the other, must understand the similarity and dissimilarity of things that are, in a precise manner.

Phaedrus: Indeed.

Socrates: Now, if someone is ignorant of the truth of something, will they be able to discern in anything else, a small or great similarity to that thing of which they are ignorant?

262b

Phaedrus: Impossible.

Socrates: In the case of people who form opinions at variance with the things that are, and who are deceived, isn't it obvious that this condition slips in by means of certain similarities?

Phaedrus: Yes, it does happen in this way.

Socrates: Now, is there any way that someone could be skilful in shifting people, little by little by means of similarities, away from what is, and lead them to its opposite? Or could someone avoid this situation, if the person had not recognised what each of those things that are, actually is?

Phaedrus: Never.

262c

Socrates: So, my friend, a person who does not know the truth but who chases instead after opinions will, it seems, exhibit a ridiculously unskilled skill in speaking.

Phaedrus: Quite likely.

Socrates: Would you like to look for the features we have called skilled and unskilled in the speech of Lysias that you are carrying, and in those I delivered?

Phaedrus: Oh, more than anything. Yes, at the moment we are speaking in an abstract way without having enough examples.

262d

Socrates: And, indeed, by some chance, it seems that the two speeches that have been delivered provide an example of the fact that someone who knows the truth may mislead those who hear by playing with words. And I myself, Phaedrus, blame the gods of this place, and perhaps also those prophets of the Muses who are singing above our heads, and who may have breathed this gift into us, for I do not presume to partake of any skill in speaking.

Phaedrus: Be that as it may, just clarify what you are saying.

Socrates: Then go ahead and read me the beginning of Lysias' speech.

262e

Phaedrus: “You know about my affairs, and you have heard how I think it best for us to arrange things. But I do not deserve to fail in my request just because I am not actually your lover, since in the case of lovers there is regret...”

Socrates: Stop! You should now say what error he makes, and what he does that is unskilled. Is that right?

263a

Phaedrus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, isn't it obvious to everyone that in general we are like-minded on some issues of this sort, and at variance on some others?

Phaedrus: I think I understand what you mean, but please explain it even more clearly.

Socrates: Whenever someone utters the word for iron or silver, don't we all think of the same thing?

Phaedrus: Very much so.

Socrates: But what happens if someone refers to justice and injustice? Isn't there a divergence, and don't we dispute with one another and with ourselves?

Phaedrus: We certainly do.

263b

Socrates: So in some cases we are in accord, and in others we are not.

Phaedrus: Quite so.

Socrates: Now, in which of these two cases will we be more easily deceived, and in which case will rhetoric be more powerful?

Phaedrus: Obviously in the cases where we are uncertain.

263c

Socrates: Therefore, a person who intends to develop a skill in rhetoric must first distinguish these methodically and apprehend some characteristic of each of the two forms, the one in which most people are bound to be uncertain, and the one in which they are not.

Phaedrus: Socrates, even if someone had just apprehended this latter form, something worthwhile would have been understood.

Socrates: And then, whenever the person is dealing with a particular instance, I think that person should not be oblivious as to which of the two kinds the intended subject belongs. No, there is a need to be keenly aware of this.

Phaedrus: Of course.

Socrates: Well, should we say that love is one of the controversial issues, or is it uncontroversial?

Phaedrus: Presumably it is one of the controversial subjects, otherwise how would it be possible for you to say what you have said about it just now, that it is harmful both to the loved one and to the lover, and then again that it is among the greatest goods?

263d

Socrates: Excellently expressed! But tell me this too – for to tell you the truth, because of my inspired state I cannot really remember – whether I defined love at the beginning of the speech.

Phaedrus: Yes, by Zeus! You placed considerable emphasis on that.

Socrates: Oh! To this extent, you are saying that when it comes to speeches, the Nymphs, daughters of Achelous, and Pan, the son of Hermes, are more skilled than Lysias, the son of Cephalus. Or am I talking nonsense, and did Lysias, at the beginning of his

speech concerned with love, compel us to accept that love was one of the things that are, a particular that he himself had in mind, and did he then arrange all of the rest of the speech in relation to this and bring it to a conclusion? Would you like us to read the beginning of it once more?

263e

Phaedrus: If you think we should, but what you are looking for is not in it.

Socrates: Recite it anyway so that I may hear the man himself.

Phaedrus: “You know about my affairs, and you have heard how I think it best for us to arrange things. But I do not deserve to fail in my request just because I am not actually your lover, since in the case of lovers there is regret for any good they may have done, once the desire comes to an end.”

264a

Socrates: It seems that this fellow really does fall far short of supplying what we are looking for. He does not even begin at the beginning but at the end, and he attempts to swim through the speech on his back, in reverse, and starts from those things which a lover would say to his favourite when he had concluded. Or have I spoken nonsense, Phaedrus, my dear one?

Phaedrus: Anyway, Socrates, I grant you he is making a speech about an ending.

264b

Socrates: What about the rest of it? Don't the other parts of the speech seem to have been thrown together at random? Does the second thing he said need to be placed second for any compelling reason, or indeed his other pronouncements? For it seemed to me, although I know nothing about this, that the writer, in a somewhat dignified manner, just uttered whatever occurred to him. But do you know any requirement of speechwriting according to which the man has placed these

elements together in this particular order?

Phaedrus: It is kind of you to think that I am up to the task of understanding the man's pronouncements in such a precise manner.

264c

Socrates: But I think you could say this much anyway: every speech must be constructed just like a living creature with a body of its own, so that it is neither headless nor footless; instead it should be written possessing middle and extremities suited to one another and to the whole.

Phaedrus: Of course.

Socrates: Then consider whether your friend's speech is arranged like this or not, and you will find that it is no different from the inscription which, some say, is inscribed on the tomb of Midas of Phrygia.

264d

Phaedrus: What is it like? And what characteristic are you referring to?

Socrates: Well, the inscription is this: 264d A Maiden of bronze on Midas' tomb I lie As long as water flows and trees grow tall Here I remain on his much-lamented grave Proclaiming to passers-by that Midas is buried here 264e But I presume you recognise that it makes no difference which line you recite first or last.

Phaedrus: You are mocking this speech of ours, Socrates.

264e

Socrates: Well then, let us leave this speech aside in case you get upset. And yet I think it does contain many examples which it would be beneficial to examine, but not at all beneficial to imitate. Instead, we should proceed to the other speeches, for there was something in them, I believe, that anyone who wishes to study speeches would do well to observe.

265a

Phaedrus: What sort of thing are you referring to?

Socrates: There were, in a sense, two opposing speeches. One stated that it is necessary to favour the lover, the other the non-lover.

Phaedrus: And most assertively too.

Socrates: I thought you were going to speak the truth and say ‘madly’. Anyway, that’s the very word I was looking for. In fact, we said that love is a madness, didn’t we?

Phaedrus: Yes.

Socrates: Yes, but there are two forms of madness, the one arising from human disorders, and the other from a divine alteration of habitual attitudes.

265b

Phaedrus: Entirely so.

Socrates: And we distinguished four categories of divine madness belonging to four gods. The prophetic kind was assigned to the inspiration of Apollo, the mystical to Dionysus, the poetical in turn to the Muses, and the fourth kind to Aphrodite and to Love, and we declared that this madness of love is the very best. Now, I do not know what the experience of love should be compared to. Perhaps we have made some connection with truth, perhaps instead we have been borne off in the wrong direction. Having blended a speech that is not entirely unconvincing, we chanted a hymn in the form of a story, with measure and with solemnity, in praise of your master and mine, Phaedrus, Love, the guardian of beautiful boys.

265c

Phaedrus: And it was very pleasant for me to hear it.

Socrates: Then let us use this fact in order to understand how the speech was able to switch from censure to praise.

Phaedrus: What aspect are you actually referring to?

265d

Socrates: It appears to me, for the most part, to have played a veritable game, and yet among these random pronouncements there were two forms, and if we were able, by some skill, to understand the potential of both, that would be most worthwhile.

Phaedrus: What were they?

Socrates: The first takes a collective view of things that are dispersed and multifarious and brings them into one form so that each is defined, and whatever you wish to impart on any occasion is made clear. It is like what we did just now in the case of love. Once we had defined what it is, whether adequately or inadequately, the speech was able, because of that, to state what was obvious and what was in agreement with itself.

Phaedrus: And what is the other form you mentioned, Socrates?

265e

Socrates: The ability to cut it up once more on the basis of forms, according to its natural joints, without trying to shatter a single part by going about it like a bad butcher. And just as our two recent speeches grasped the unreasoning part of the mind as a single common form, and just as the parts of a single body naturally appear in pairs with the same name, although one is on the left and the other on the right, so also did the two speeches regard the mental disorder in us as, by nature, a single form. One speech took the part cut from the left-hand side, cut this once more, and did not relent until, having found what you might call a left-sided love among them, it reviled this and was quite right to do so. The other speech, leading us through the parts of madness of the right-hand side, found and presented a love with the same name as the other one, except that it was

divine, and it praised this as the cause of the greatest benefits that accrue to us.

266b

Phaedrus: What you are saying is entirely true.

Socrates: Now, I myself, dear Phaedrus, am a lover of these processes of division and combination, so that I may be able to speak and to think. And if I believe that anyone else is able to discern a one in what is by nature multiple, I follow him 'wherever he leads as though he were a god'.²⁸ And indeed up until now I have referred to people who are able to do this as dialecticians, but whether or not I am describing them correctly, God knows. Now, tell me what we should call those who are instructed by yourself and Lysias. Do they go by the name of that skill in speaking which Thrasymachus and the others employ in order to become wise speakers themselves, and make others wise once they are prepared to bear gifts to them as though they were kings?

266c

Phaedrus: They are kingly men indeed, but when it comes to the processes you are asking about, they are not knowledgeable. Indeed, I think you are referring to this form correctly when you call it dialectic, and I think that rhetoric, for its part, is still escaping us.

Socrates: What do you mean? Could there be anything of merit which has been deprived of these two processes and is regarded as a skill in any case? You and I should not show total disrespect, but we should also describe the part of rhetoric that is still left.

266d

Phaedrus: Yes, Socrates, presumably there is a great deal of material in the books that have been written about the skill of speech making.

Socrates: Your reminder is well timed. In the first place, I think that a preamble needs to be delivered at the beginning of the speech. Is that so? Are these what you mean by the refinements of the skill?

Phaedrus: Yes.

266e

Socrates: And then, in second place, is an exposition and evidence to support it. Third are proofs and fourth come probabilities. And that superlative speech craftsman, the man from Byzantium, refers I believe to confirmation and added confirmation.

Phaedrus: You mean the worthy Theodorus?

Socrates: Of course. And he says we should employ refutation and added refutation, both in accusation and in defence. And can we avoid bringing in the superb Evenus of Paros,²⁹ who was first to discover insinuation and incidental praise? And according to some people, he also recites incidental censures in verse to help his memory. A wise man indeed!

267a

Socrates: Shall we leave Tisias and Gorgias undisturbed,³⁰ these men who have realised that appearances are more honourable than truth; and who also use force of speech to make minor issues appear important, and important issues appear minor; novelties appear ancient, and ancient truths appear novel; men who discovered how to speak concisely or interminably on any subject whatsoever? Now, when Prodicus³¹ heard me mention this he laughed, and said that he alone had discovered what skilled speech making involves: the speeches should be neither long nor short but duly measured.

267b

Phaedrus: Dear Prodicus, what unparalleled wisdom!

Socrates: And we shall not mention Hippias,³² for I believe this stranger from Elis would vote the same way as Prodicus.

Phaedrus: Why wouldn't he?

267c

Socrates: And how shall we describe Polus³³ and his array of inspired expressions such as 'double-speech' and 'concise-speech' and 'image-speech', and phrases that Licymnius³⁴ gave him in order to produce eloquence.

Phaedrus: Weren't there Protagorean³⁵ works of this kind too, Socrates?

Socrates: Yes, my boy, he wrote 'Proper Diction' and numerous other fine works. Then again, the Chalcedonian giant³⁶ appears, quite skilfully, to have mastered lamentations on old age and poverty in long, drawn-out speeches, and this man, so he says, has become formidable at arousing crowds to anger, and appeasing them again by means of his charms, once they are angry. And he is a master of slander, and of the repudiation of slander, regardless of the source. And yet, when it comes to the conclusion of speeches, they all seem to agree with one another, although some use the term 'recapitulation' while others give it a different name.

267d

Phaedrus: Do you mean reminding your hearers towards the end of the speech of the various issues that have been referred to?

Socrates: That is what I mean. And if you have anything else to say about the skill of speaking...

Phaedrus: Minor matters, not worth mentioning.

268a

Socrates: Well, let us leave the minor issues aside and let us look at the others in a brighter light, and see what power they derive from this skill, and when.

Phaedrus: And it is very powerful, Socrates, particularly in mass gatherings.

Socrates: It is indeed. But take a look, you heavenly creature, and see if there seem to you to be gaps in the fabric they have woven, as there seem to me to be.

Phaedrus: Just point them out to me.

268b

Socrates: Then tell me this: if someone were to approach your friend Eryximachus, or his father Acumenus, and say: “I know how to treat the body in a variety of ways so that it warms up and, if I wish, cools down; and if the idea strikes me, I can make it vomit or make its bowels move and all that sort of thing. What is more, because I know this, I am qualified to be a doctor and to make a doctor of anyone else on whom I confer the knowledge of these matters.” What do you think they would say when they heard this?

Phaedrus: Well, what else could they do but ask whether the man also knows to whom each of these treatments should be administered, and when, and for how long?

268c

Socrates: And if he were to reply, “Not at all, but I regard anyone who learns these matters from me as capable of working out for himself these details which you ask about”?

Phaedrus: I think they would say that the man is mad and believes that he has become a doctor on account of hearing something from a book or stumbling upon some minor remedies without knowing anything about the skill.

Socrates: And what if someone were to approach Sophocles and Euripides and say that he knew how to make extremely lengthy orations about a trifling matter, and very short ones about a major issue, and that he could produce lamentations at will or, in contrast, speeches that terrify and intimidate, and so on and

so forth? And what if he believed that when he passed this knowledge on, he was teaching people how to write tragedies?

268d

Phaedrus: Well, Socrates, I think that they would be amused by anyone who believed that tragedy was anything other than the proper arrangement of these elements with respect to one another, and to the play as a whole.

Socrates: But I do not think they would be too harsh in their criticism. No, they would respond like a musician who meets up with someone who thinks he knows what harmony is because he happens to know how to play the highest note and the lowest note on a string. He would not say fiercely, “You sorry wretch!” but like the gentle musician that he is, he would say, “Excellent fellow, anyone who intends to understand harmony must indeed have knowledge of these things. However, someone at your stage of development could still be devoid of even the smallest understanding of harmony. In fact, you know the necessary prerequisites for harmony, but not the principles of harmony.”

Phaedrus: Absolutely correct.

269a

Socrates: And wouldn’t Sophocles say that the person who is showing off to them knows the prerequisites for tragedy, but not the principles of tragedy? And in the case of Acumenus, wouldn’t he say that the person knows the prerequisites for medicine, but not the principles of medicine?

Phaedrus: Entirely so.

Socrates: But what if the honey-voiced Adrastus,³⁷ or even Pericles,³⁸ were to hear about those glorious technicalities we listed a moment ago, the aphoristic utterances and image-speaking, and anything else we described when we said they should be examined in a brighter light? Do you think they

would respond angrily, just like you and me, and direct some coarse, boorish expression at the people who have written about this, and teach it too, as though it were the skill of rhetoric? Or, since they are both wiser than us, would they rebuke us and say, “Dear Phaedrus and Socrates, you should be sympathetic, rather than angry, if some people with no knowledge of dialectic prove incapable of discerning what exactly rhetoric is, and in this predicament think they have discovered rhetoric when they know the necessary prerequisites of that skill, and actually believe they have provided comprehensive instruction to others when they teach them these prerequisites, but believe that delivering these assorted devices in a persuasive manner, and also assembling them into a whole, is an insignificant task which their pupils must figure out for themselves when they compose speeches.”?

269c

Phaedrus: Yes, certainly, Socrates. I grant you that these men write about this sort of thing and teach it as if it were the skill of rhetoric, and I think that what you have said is true. But the question is how and from where may someone acquire the genuine skill of rhetoric and persuasion?

269d

Socrates: Phaedrus, the ability to do this, and become an accomplished performer in the process, is probably acquired just like any other. In fact, it must be. If you happen to have a natural rhetorical ability, you will be a notable rhetorician once this is supplemented by knowledge and practice, but if you are lacking in any of these, you will be imperfect in that respect. However, the approach taken by Lysias and Thrasymachus does not, as I see it, recognise rhetoric as a skill.

269e

Phaedrus: Well, what should they have done?

Socrates: My friend, it is highly likely that Pericles has become the most accomplished rhetorician of them all.

Phaedrus: Why so?

270a

Socrates: All of the great skills need to be supplemented by verbose and elevated discussion about nature, for it seems that this high-mindedness and total effectiveness originate from something of this sort. And Pericles has acquired this in addition to his natural talents, for I believe he fell in with someone of this sort in the person of Anaxagoras,³⁹ and was filled full of elevated discourse, and appreciated the nature of reason and mind, the very matters on which Anaxagoras constructed an extensive argument. Pericles drew upon this and applied it, as appropriate, to the skill of speech-making.

Phaedrus: What do you mean by this?

270b

Socrates: I presume that skill in medicine works in the same way as skill in rhetoric.

Phaedrus: How so?

Socrates: In both cases we have to determine a nature; in one instance it is the nature of a body and in the other it is the nature of a soul. This is necessary if you intend to proceed by means of a skill, rather than by experience alone, either to engender health and strength by administering drugs and nutriment, or to import whatever excellence and conviction you wish into the soul through words and the cultivation of lawful habits.

Phaedrus: Yes, that sounds plausible, Socrates.

270c

Socrates: Now, do you think it is possible to discern the nature of soul adequately without discerning the nature of the whole?

Phaedrus: Well, if we are to be persuaded by Hippocrates, the Asclepiad,⁴⁰ we cannot even know about the body except through this method.

Socrates: Well said, my friend. However, in addition to the testimony of Hippocrates we should scrutinise our own account to see if it concurs with his.

Phaedrus: I agree.

Socrates: Then consider what precisely Hippocrates and the true account say regarding nature. Now, we should keep the following questions in mind in relation to the nature of anything at all. First, is it something simple or multiform in which we wish to be skilful ourselves and capable of making others skilful? Then, if it is simple, what natural capacity does it have to act, and upon what, and what capacity does it have to be acted upon by anything else? And if it has more forms than one, then we should count them, and, as in the case when there was only one, ask, in each instance, what that particular form is naturally adapted to do, or to have done to it by anything else.

Phaedrus: Very likely, Socrates.

270e

Socrates: In any case, a method devoid of these considerations would be just like the progress of a blind man. But we certainly should not liken any approach based upon a skill to the progress of the blind or the deaf. No, it is obvious that if anyone systematically imparts speech-making to another, he will reveal the essence of that nature towards which the speeches are directed, and that, I presume, will be the soul.

Phaedrus: Of course.

271a

Socrates: Therefore, all of his effort is directed towards soul, for he is attempting to bring about a conviction in the soul. Is this so?

Phaedrus: Yes.

Socrates: So it is obvious that Thrasymachus, or anyone else who seriously imparts a system of rhetoric, will in the first place write with the utmost precision, and then enable us to see whether soul is in its nature one and uniform, or multiform like the structure of the body, for this is what we mean by revealing its nature.

Phaedrus: Entirely so.

271b

Socrates: And secondly, he would clarify what by nature it enacts, by what; or what it undergoes, on account of what.

Phaedrus: Of course.

Socrates: And thirdly, once he has set out the classes of speeches and of souls, and the influence of the speeches, he will explain all this, matching each speech to a soul, and teaching us what kind of soul must, perforce, be persuaded or not persuaded by what kind of speeches, and the reason why this must be so.

Phaedrus: Well, I think that would be an excellent way to proceed.

271c

Socrates: Well then, my friend, neither this speech nor any other will ever be spoken or written by means of a skill, unless it is presented and delivered with this in view. But those who compose systems of rhetoric these days, the people you have heard of, are cunning, and they conceal the fact that they are extremely knowledgeable about the soul. So, until they describe this approach and write about it, we should not accept their claim that they are writing based upon a skill.

Phaedrus: What approach are you referring to?

Socrates: It is not easy to give you the formulations themselves, but I would like to describe the manner in which one must write if the work is to be executed as skilfully as possible.

Phaedrus: Tell me.

271d

Socrates: Since the power of speech consists in leading the soul, the one who intends to be an orator needs to know how many forms of soul there are, that their number is such and such, and there are these types and these other types, and consequently there are people of one sort and people of another sort. And then, once he has categorised souls in this way, there are also various forms of speeches, each with its own qualities. People of a certain kind are easily persuaded to particular viewpoints by speeches of this sort for this reason, while these other people are difficult to persuade for these other reasons. And once he has a proper understanding of these factors and can also see them in operation in practical situations, he must be able to pay keen attention to them or he will derive no benefit, as yet, from the instructions he heard whilst attending the lectures.

271e

Socrates: And when he has the competence to state that this sort of person is persuaded by speeches of this sort, he is able to recognise that person if he happens to meet him, and satisfy himself that the person now standing before him represents a particular nature which was once described in lectures, a nature to which he will have to apply certain speeches in a particular way to persuade it in certain directions; once he has understood all this, and has also appreciated when it is time to speak or to refrain from speaking, and recognises the right time and the wrong time for the aphorisms, lamentations, intensifications or any of the other rhetorical devices he has learned, then and not till then does his skill in rhetoric attain complete and glorious consummation. But if someone ignores these principles when

he teaches or speaks or writes, but still claims to speak by means of a skill, it is best not to believe him. But perhaps our fellow author will ask, “Well then, Socrates and Phaedrus, is that it? Is there no other way to describe the skill of speech-making than this?”

272b

Phaedrus: I think it is impossible to describe it in any other way, Socrates, although it is turning out to be no minor undertaking.

272c

Socrates: True! For this reason we should scrutinise all the arguments from every angle to see if some easier, shorter means of attaining this skill turns up, so that we do not go off in vain down a long, rough road when there is a short and smooth one. But if you have any kind of assistance to offer from what you have heard from Lysias or anyone else, try to remember it and tell me.

Phaedrus: I would have something to say if it were just a matter of trying, but at the moment I have nothing to offer.

Socrates: Then would you like me to recount an argument I have heard from some people who are concerned with these issues?

Phaedrus: What is it?

Socrates: Anyway, Phaedrus, it is said that even the wolf deserves to have his say.

272d

Phaedrus: Then you should take his part.

Socrates: Well, some people say that these issues do not have to be made so solemn and principled through such lengthy elaboration. For as we said at the start of this discussion, when it comes to issues of good and right, or men who possess such qualities either naturally or through education, the one who

intends to be a rhetorician need not be concerned with truth in any way at all. For in the law courts, they say, no one at all cares one jot about the truth of these matters. No, they care about persuasion, and what is persuasive is what is likely, so anyone who intends to speak skilfully should pay attention to this. In fact, sometimes one should not even refer to the actual events if they occurred in an unlikely manner. Instead, one should describe likely events whether in a prosecution or a defence, and in all that is said one should pursue likelihood and, for the most part, bid farewell to the truth. For this, when maintained throughout the entire speech, represents the sum total of the skill of rhetoric.

273a

Phaedrus: Yes, Socrates, the men who make out that they are skilled speechmakers say what you have just said. In fact, I recall that we touched upon this sort of issue briefly in our earlier discussion, but it seems to be extremely important to those who are concerned with these things.

273b

Socrates: And indeed you have made a careful study of Tisias himself, so let Tisias inform us too. He says that likelihood is nothing other than ‘how things seem to most people’.

Phaedrus: What else could it be?

Socrates: Yes, it is quite likely that in the light of this wise and skilful insight, he wrote that if a weak brave man beats up a strong coward and steals his cloak or something else, and is brought before a court, neither of them should speak the truth. Instead the coward, for his part, should say that the brave man was not acting alone when he beat him up, while the other fellow should retort that there was only the pair of them, and should have recourse to the standard defence, ‘How could a man like me have taken on a man like this?’ Then the other chap will not mention his cowardice but, in his efforts to come

up with some other lie, will probably furnish his opponent with a counterargument. And, indeed, whatever the situation, this is the sort of thing that the skilled speaker says. Isn't this so, Phaedrus?

Phaedrus: Of course.

273c

Socrates: Gosh! Tisias, or someone else, whoever he is, and whatever he likes to be named after, has discovered a skill that has been most ingeniously hidden! Yet, my friend, there is something we should say to him, or perhaps not...

Phaedrus: What?

273d

Socrates: This. "Dear Tisias, a while ago, before you joined us, we happened to be saying that this notion of likelihood tends to arise in most people because of likenesses to the truth. But we explained earlier that the person who knows the truth is best equipped in every respect to discover the likenesses. So, if you say anything else about the skill of speaking we shall listen, but if not, we shall believe what we have already explained, that unless someone enumerates the various natures among his prospective audience, and distinguishes things that are on the basis of forms, and unless he is capable of comprehending each particular through a single characteristic, he will never be skilled at speaking to the extent that a human being can be. But these abilities will never be acquired without a great deal of effort which a wise man should undertake, not for purposes of speaking and acting towards his fellow men, but in order to be capable of speaking what is acceptable to the gods, and of acting to his utmost capacity in a manner acceptable to them. Well, there it is, Tisias. Those who are wiser than us proclaim that a man of reason should be concerned, not with gratifying his fellow slaves, except incidentally, but with gratifying his masters who are good in every way. So don't be surprised if the

journey is a long and circuitous one, for we should take the circuitous route in pursuit of exalted objectives, and not the objectives that concern you. And yet according to this argument, if you want these objectives they are best produced from exalted ones.”

274a

Phaedrus: I think you are describing this gloriously, Socrates. If only someone could enact it.

Socrates: But it is good for someone who strives for the good to accept whatever may befall him.

Phaedrus: Very much so.

Socrates: Well, that is enough said about skill and absence of skill in speaking.

Phaedrus: Indeed.

Socrates: We are left with the question of the appropriateness and inappropriateness of writing, and how it may be executed in a worthy or an inappropriate manner. Do you agree?

Phaedrus: Yes.

274b

Socrates: Do you know how best to please a god with speeches, either by performing them or discussing them?

Phaedrus: Not at all. Do you?

Socrates: Anyway I can tell what I have heard from those who have gone before us, but they are the ones who know the truth. Yet if we were to discover it ourselves, would any of the preoccupations of humanity still concern us?

Phaedrus: It is ridiculous to ask that question but do tell me what you say you have heard.

274c

Socrates: Well, I heard that at Naucratis⁴¹ in Egypt there was a certain ancient god of that place, whose sacred bird is the one they call the Ibis, while the name of the divine being himself was Theuth.⁴² He was first to discover number and calculation, geometry and astronomy, and also draughts and dice, and of course writing. Now, at that time, Thamus⁴³ was king of all Egypt round about the great city of the upper region. The Greeks call this city Egyptian Thebes and they refer to Thamus as Ammon. Theuth went to this king to show off his discoveries, and he proposed that they should be passed on to the rest of the Egyptians, and Thamus asked what benefit each of them possessed, and as Theuth explained this he praised whatever seemed worthwhile and criticised whatever did not. Now, Thamus is said to have expressed many views both positive and negative to Theuth about each of the skills, so an account of these would be quite lengthy. But when he came to writing, Theuth said, “This branch of learning, O King, will make the Egyptians wiser and give them better memories, for I have discovered an elixir of both memory and wisdom.” The king replied, “Oh most ingenious Theuth, one man is able to invent these skills, but a different person is capable of judging their benefit or harm to those who will use them. And you, as the father of writing, on account of your positive attitude, are now saying that it does the opposite of what it is able to do. This subject will engender forgetfulness in the souls of those who learn it, for they will not make use of memory. Because of their faith in writing, they will be reminded externally by means of unfamiliar marks, and not from within themselves by means of themselves. So, you have discovered an elixir not of memory but of reminding. You will provide the students with a semblance of wisdom, not true wisdom. For having heard a great deal without any teaching, they will seem to be extremely knowledgeable, when for the most part they are ignorant, and are difficult people to be with because they have attained a

seeming wisdom without being wise.”

275b

Phaedrus: Oh, Socrates, it is so easy for you to make up stories about Egypt or anywhere else you please!

Socrates: And yet, my friend, the people in the sanctuary of Zeus at Dodona said the first prophetic utterances were the words of an oak tree. Of course, the men of that time were not as wise as you moderns, and it was enough for them, on account of their simple-mindedness, to listen to oak trees or rocks if they only spoke the truth. But it probably makes a difference to you who the speaker is and where he comes from. Do you not consider the only relevant issue to be whether or not these things are so?

275c

Phaedrus: You are right to rebuke me, and I do think that what the Theban king says about writing is correct.

Socrates: Then a person who thinks he has left a skill in writing behind him, and anyone who, for his part, inherits this on the assumption that something clear and certain will emerge from writing, would be full of enormous silliness, and indeed ignorant of the prophetic words of Ammon in believing that written words are anything more than a reminder to a person who already knows whatever it is that the written words may refer to.

Phaedrus: Correct.

275d

Socrates: Yes, Phaedrus, I think that writing has a strange feature that makes it quite like painting. For the offspring of the painter’s skill stand before us like living creatures, but if you ask them a question, they are very solemnly silent. And the same goes for written words. You might assume that they are speaking with some degree of intelligence, but if you wish to

learn from them and you ask them a question about what they are saying, they just point to one thing and it is always the same. And once they have been written down, every word is bandied about indiscriminately to people who understand it, and to those for whom it is not appropriate at all, and it does not know to whom it should speak and to whom it should not. And when it is ill-treated or unjustly criticised the word always needs its father to come to its aid, for it is unable either to defend or assist itself.

275e

Phaedrus: You are perfectly right about that.

276a

Socrates: Well then, do we see another word, the legitimate brother of this one, the manner in which it arises and how much more excellently and powerfully it develops?

Phaedrus: What is it and how do you say it arises?

Socrates: The word that is written, along with knowledge, in the soul of the one who is learning, capable of defending itself, yet knowing to whom it should speak and with whom it should be silent.

Phaedrus: You are talking about the living and ensouled word of the man who knows, of which the written word may rightly be called an image.

276b

Socrates: Entirely so. Now, tell me this. Would a farmer who possesses intelligence, holding seeds that he cares about and wants to see as fruit, sow them in all seriousness in summer in some garden of Adonis,⁴⁴ and delight in beholding the manifestation of their beauty within eight days? Or, if he were to do this at all, would he do it only for the sake of amusement at a festival? But if he were serious about these, wouldn't he have recourse to the skill of husbandry, and having sown them

in the appropriate soil, be content if whatever he had sown attained perfection in the eighth month?

276c

Phaedrus: Yes, Socrates, I think he would be acting seriously in one situation and quite differently in the other, just as you say.

Socrates: And are we to say that somebody who has knowledge of things just and beautiful and good has any less insight than the farmer in relation to his own seeds?

Phaedrus: Not the slightest.

Socrates: So this person will not, with any seriousness, write them in black water, sowing them through a pen, along with words that are unable to come to their own aid in a discussion, and also are unable to teach the truth adequately.

Phaedrus: No, that is most unlikely.

276d

Socrates: No indeed! But if he does write he will, it seems, sow and write his gardens of letters for the sake of amusement, storing up reminders both for himself when he arrives at the forgetfulness of old age, and for everyone else who follows the same trail, and he will take delight in beholding their tender growth. And while others have recourse to amusements of a different sort, deluging themselves at drinking parties and pursuing a variety of related pastimes, this man, it seems, will prefer to spend his time in the amusements I have described.

276e

Phaedrus: You are describing a glorious game, Socrates, alongside a mundane one, the pastime of a man who is able to play with words, telling stories about justice and the other topics you are referring to.

Socrates: It is indeed, dear Phaedrus. But I think it is far better to become serious about these matters as when someone, through recourse to the skill of dialectic, takes a fitting soul and

plants and sows words based on knowledge; words that are sufficient to assist themselves and the one who planted them; that are not fruitless, but possess a seed from which others grow in other natures; able to render the seed ever immortal, and make the one who possesses it blessed to the fullest possible extent of human blessedness.

277a

Phaedrus: Yes, the approach you are describing is far better.

Socrates: Well, now that we have come to an agreement about these matters, Phaedrus, we can decide about those other issues too.

Phaedrus: What issues?

Socrates: Well, it was the desire to look at those issues that brought us to this point, the manner in which we might investigate the criticism of Lysias on the grounds of being a speechwriter, and whether the speeches themselves were written by means of a skill or without one. Now, I think that this presence or absence of skill has been explained well enough.

Phaedrus: Yes, so it seemed anyway, but remind me again of how we did it.

277b

Socrates: Our entire previous discussion has revealed that until someone knows the truth of each of the matters about which he is speaking or writing and has developed the ability to define the whole by itself, and once he has defined this, knows how to cut it up again on the basis of forms as far as what cannot be cut. And until he understands the nature of soul on the same basis, discovering the form appropriate to each nature, and arranges and constructs his speech accordingly, presenting variegated and elaborate words to a complex soul and simple words to a simpler soul, he will not be able to engage, with skill, in the practice of speechmaking to the extent that nature allows,

neither for the purposes of instruction nor for the purposes of persuasion.

Phaedrus: Yes, absolutely! This is what our discussion has shown.

277d

Socrates: But what about the question of delivering and writing speeches, and whether this is noble or shameful, and the sense in which the activity may properly become a matter of reproach or praise? Haven't our earlier explanations dealt with this?

Phaedrus: What explanations?

Socrates: That if Lysias or anyone else has ever written or will ever write, either in private or as a public lawmaker writing a political treatise, in the belief that there is any great certainty or clarity therein, this behaviour is a reproach to the writer whether someone actually expresses this or not. For a person who cannot tell a dream of justice and injustice or good and evil from the reality will never, in truth, escape reproach even if the entire populace applauds it.

Phaedrus: Not at all.

277e

Socrates: But the person who realises that in a written discourse on any topic there must be a great deal that is playful; that not one composition in verse or in prose that deserves to be taken seriously has yet been written, nor has any been expounded as the rhapsodes do, without any analysis or instruction, in order to produce persuasion; that in reality the best of these speeches act as a reminder to those who already know; that only in what is taught or spoken for the sake of instruction, and is actually inscribed in the soul in relation to the just and beautiful and good, is there clarity and perfection and anything worth taking seriously; a person who realises that words such as these should be referred to as his own legitimate

sons, the first being the one within himself, if it be found there, and then any offspring and brothers of this which may have sprung up in a worthy manner at the same time in other souls of other persons, and who bids farewell to any other words; this, Phaedrus, is surely the sort of person that you and I would each pray to become.

278b

Phaedrus: Entirely so. What you are describing is just what I wish for and pray for.

Socrates: Well then, let that be the extent of our entertainment with speeches. You should go now and tell Lysias that we both went down to the river and sacred place of the Nymphs, and we heard words directing us to send a message to Lysias and anyone else who composes speeches; to Homer or anyone else who, for his part, has composed poetry in verse or in song; and thirdly, to Solon and anyone who has written political speeches and given them the name of laws. The message is that if he composed these knowing where the truth lies, and if he can provide support when the views he set down are challenged, and is able to demonstrate when he himself is speaking that his written words are of lesser rate, then a man of this sort should not be given a name associated with those literary activities, but should be named after the matters he takes seriously.

278d

Phaedrus: What will you call him then?

Socrates: I think it would be a big step, Phaedrus, to call him ‘wise’ because this is appropriate only for a god. The title ‘lover of wisdom’ or something of that sort would suit him better and would be more modest.

Phaedrus: And not inappropriate either.

278e

Socrates: And wouldn't you be quite right to refer to someone as a poet or speechwriter or law writer if he, for his part, possesses nothing of more value than what he has composed or written through various twists and turns, adding bits on and taking bits away over the course of time?

Phaedrus: Of course.

Socrates: Then tell all this to your friend.

Phaedrus: But what about you? What will you do? Your friend should not be overlooked either.

Socrates: Who is that?

Phaedrus: The fair Isocrates.⁴⁵ What message will you give to him, Socrates? What will we say that he is?

279a

Socrates: Isocrates is still young, Phaedrus. Yet I would like to say what I prophesy for him.

Phaedrus: Oh! What is it?

Socrates: I think that his natural endowments are superior to the speeches of Lysias, and there is a nobler blend in his character. So it would be no surprise, in view of his current interest in discourse, if he were to make all those who have previously taken to speech look no better than children in comparison, once he comes of age, especially if these pursuits do not satisfy him and some more divine impulse leads him to the greater; for my friend, there is some philosophy present by nature in the mind of that man. So, these are the words I convey from the gods of this place to Isocrates, as my beloved, while you convey those other words to Lysias, as yours.

279b

Phaedrus: So be it. Then let us depart now that the heat has died down.

Socrates: Is it not surely appropriate to pray to the gods of the place before leaving?

Phaedrus: Of course.

Socrates: O beloved Pan and any other gods who are here, grant that I may become beautiful within, and that all my outer possessions be in friendly concord with the inner. May I regard the wise as the wealthy, and may I have as much gold as only a sound-minded person could bear and carry. Need we say anything else, Phaedrus? That prayer is enough for me.

279c

Phaedrus: Let me join in that prayer too, for friends have all things in common.

Socrates: Let us go.

NOTES

1. Cephalus features in book I of Plato's *Republic*, along with his son Polemarchus. The discussion depicted in that dialogue takes place in Cephalus' house in Piraeus. His son Lysias, a noted writer of speeches, was present at that gathering but did not speak.
2. Acumenus was a physician and friend of Socrates. His son Eryximachus appears in Plato's *Symposium*.
3. Morychus is noted in a number of Aristophanes' plays for his luxurious lifestyle.
4. Pindar, *Isthmian* i.2.
5. Herodicus was a physician whose exercise regime involved walking to the city walls from some distance away and then turning back.
6. According to legend, Boreas, the god of the cold north wind, kidnapped the Athenian princess Orithyia as she played with Nymphs on the banks of the Ilissus, a river outside the walls of Athens, to the east.
7. Typho, a giant monster, was one of the deadliest creatures in Greek mythology. His complexity stems from his one hundred heads and his multiform physique comprised of a humanoid winged torso atop two snake-tail legs.
8. Achelous was a river god, personified as water and associated with the river of the same name, the longest in Greece. Nymphs were minor deities associated with different aspects of the natural world.
9. Sappho and Anacreon were lyric poets, both included among the canonical Nine Lyric Poets of ancient Greece. Sappho was regarded as one of the greatest lyric poets; Anacreon was noted for his drinking songs and erotic poetry.
10. The Nine Archons were officials of the city of Athens, chosen by lot. Their oath of office stipulated that they would undertake to erect a golden statue as a penalty if they transgressed any of the laws.
11. The Cypselid dynasty ruled over Corinth during its golden age. A chest in which the baby Cypselus, founder of the dynasty, was said to have been hidden by his mother to protect him from assassins was housed as a votive offering at Olympia.
12. A line from Pindar, *Fragment* 82, Bergk.
13. Simmias was a Pythagorean philosopher from Thebes, and an associate of Socrates. He was present at Socrates' execution, and is one of the two

main interlocutors in Plato's dialogue *Phaedo*.

14. Ibycus was a lyric poet from Rhegium in Magna Graeca. He was counted among the Nine Lyric Poets of ancient Greece.

15. Stesichorus was a lyric poet who was counted among the Nine Lyric Poets of ancient Greece. According to legend, he was blinded, and then had his sight restored, for composing first critical, then laudatory poems about Helen of Troy.

16. *Fragment 18*, Edmonds.

17. Delphi and Dodona were two important prophetic sacred sites in the ancient Greek world. Both of them housed oracles. Delphi was more famous, but Dodona was more ancient.

18. The phrase 'all soul' may also be translated 'every soul'.

19. Literally, a 'lover of wisdom'.

20. Socrates here suggests that the Greek word *himeros* (longing) comes from the words *ienai* (go forth), *rhein* (flow), and *merē* (portions/particles). See also *Cratylus* 420a.

21. Bacchants were devotees of Dionysus who were thought to achieve supernatural abilities when possessed by the god.

22. Ganymede was a Trojan youth who was abducted by the gods to serve as Zeus' cup-bearer. The story of the relationship between Zeus and Ganymede was used to justify the Greek social custom of relationships between older men and adolescent boys.

23. These three were a Spartan lawgiver, an Athenian lawgiver and a Persian King, respectively.

24. *Iliad* ii.361.

25. Nestor and Odysseus are Homeric heroes who are particularly skilful orators. Palamedes, though not mentioned by Homer, was noted for his guile, especially in successfully convincing Odysseus to join the Trojan expedition.

26. Gorgias of Leontini was the most formidable teacher of rhetoric at the time. His visit to Athens is immortalised in Plato's eponymous dialogue. Little is known about Thrasymachus of Chalcedon, apart from the role he is depicted as playing in Plato's *Republic*. Theodorus of Byzantium was, like Gorgias and Thrasymachus, a famous rhetorician.

27. The Eleatic Palamedes is generally agreed to be Zeno of Elea, a companion of Parmenides, who produced a number of influential

paradoxes about motion, and who is depicted in Plato's dialogue *Parmenides* advancing arguments of the kind described here.

28. *Odyssey* ii.406.

29. Evenus of Paros was a late 5th-century sophist and teacher. He is also mentioned in Plato's *Apology* (20b-c) and *Phaedo* (60d, 61b-c).

30. Tisias of Syracuse, along with his teacher Corax, is credited with founding the Sicilian school of rhetoric, which was practised by Gorgias.

31. Prodicus of Ceos was a contemporary of Socrates. Plato often mentions him and his insistence on the correct use of words. He appears in the *Protagoras*.

32. Hippias of Elis was a travelling teacher who claimed to be an authority on all subjects. He features prominently in two eponymous dialogues and in the *Protagoras*.

33. Polus was a close associate of Gorgias, and is depicted in Plato's dialogue *Gorgias*.

34. Licymnius of Chios was a dithyrambic poet and rhetorician.

35. Protagoras of Abdera was an influential sophist and teacher of rhetoric. He is depicted in Plato's eponymous dialogue, and positions attributed to him are considered in Plato's *Theaetetus*.

36. The Chalcedonian giant is Thrasy machus.

37. Adrastus was a legendary king of Argos and the leader of the Seven Against Thebes. He features prominently in the work of Pindar, and is a main character in Euripides' *The Suppliants*. The quote is from the Spartan elegiac poet Tertius (*Fragment* 12.8, Edmonds).

38. Pericles was the most influential Athenian politician and orator of the Classical period.

39. Anaxagoras was a natural philosopher and close associate of Pericles. He was from Clazomenae in Ionia, and lived a generation before Socrates. He famously maintained that mind (*nous*) is the ordering force in the cosmos. His views are discussed in greater detail in Plato's *Phaedo* (97b ff.).

40. Hippocrates was a physician from the island of Kos. A younger contemporary of Socrates, he is regarded as one of the most influential figures in the history of medicine, and lends his name to the Hippocratic Oath. The epithet 'Asclepiad' refers to the connection ancient physicians had with Asclepius, the god of medicine in Greek religion and the personification of its healing power.

41. Naucratis was a Greek trading post in ancient Egypt. It was situated on the westernmost branch of the Nile.

42. Theuth (or Thoth) was the Egyptian god of writing, calculation, science and judgement. He was often depicted with the head of an ibis or baboon. The Greeks associated him with Hermes. He also appears in an account of the creation of the alphabet in Plato's *Philebus* (18b).

43. Thamus, or Ammon, was the king of the gods in Egyptian mythology. He eventually became associated with the sun god, Ra. For the Greeks he became associated with Zeus.

44. Gardens of Adonis were small containers in which devotees would force plants (lettuce and fennel) to sprout briefly and then die in order to commemorate the death of Adonis, the consort of Aphrodite.

45. Isocrates was a rhetorician, teacher and contemporary of Plato. He was one of the ten Attic orators. He established a school in Athens, which was a rival to Plato's Academy.

Philebus

ΦΙΛΗΒΟΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

PROTARCHUS son of Callias, a very rich Athenian

PHILEBUS nothing is known

scene: no indication

11a

Socrates: Well, Protarchus, be clear now as to what argument you are about to accept from Philebus, and what argument of mine you are to oppose if it does not accord with your thinking. Would you like us to summarise both?

11b

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: So Philebus, for his part, says that what is good for every creature is enjoyment, pleasure and delight, and anything else that belongs to this class. Whereas I contend that not these, but understanding, reasoning, memory and their kindred, right opinion and true thinking, are better and more desirable than pleasure for all of those who are able to acquire them, and that they are supremely beneficial to anyone who can attain them now or in the future. Isn't that the sort of thing we both said, Philebus?

11c

Philebus: Yes, entirely so, Socrates.

Socrates: Well, Protarchus, do you accept the argument that has just been assigned to you?

Protarchus: I must accept it, since the fair Philebus has withdrawn.

Socrates: In that case, should we somehow ascertain the truth about this by all possible means?

Protarchus: Yes, we should.

11d

Socrates: Well then, let us agree on something else besides this.

Protarchus: On what?

Socrates: That each of us will now be attempting to indicate some state or disposition of the soul, capable of providing a happy life to all people. Is this not so?

Protarchus: This is so.

Socrates: Will you say that the state is one of enjoyment, while I in turn say that it is one of understanding?

Protarchus: That's it.

Socrates: And what if some other state turns out to be better than these? In that case, if it proves to be more akin to pleasure, then both our suggestions would be inferior to the life based firmly upon that condition, while the life of pleasure would be superior to that of understanding. Is this so?

12a

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: But if it is more akin to understanding, would understanding be victorious over pleasure, and would pleasure be inferior? Do you say that this is now agreed? Or what do you say?

Protarchus: Well, I think so anyway.

Socrates: And what about Philebus? What do you say?

Philebus: It seems to me that pleasure is and will be completely victorious, but you will recognise this yourself, Protarchus.

Protarchus: Having handed the argument over to me, Philebus, you may no longer control my agreements with Socrates, or the disagreements either.

12b

Philebus: What you say is true. In fact, I now renounce it, and call the goddess herself as witness.

Protarchus: And we shall act as your supporting witnesses to the fact that you have said this. Anyway, Socrates, we should try to proceed to the next stages of our discussion, regardless of the willingness of Philebus or his wishes.

12c

Socrates: We should try, beginning with the actual goddess herself, who Philebus here says is called Aphrodite, even though her truest name is Pleasure.

Protarchus: Absolutely correct.

Socrates: Protarchus, my constant awe in relation to the names of the gods is not quite human. No, it is beyond the greatest fear. So, I shall now address Aphrodite in whichever manner is dear to that goddess. However, I know that pleasure is complex, and, as I said, it is necessary to begin with that, and reflect on and consider the sort of nature it possesses. In fact, it sounds as if it is only one thing, yet it has assumed multiple forms, and these are in some way unlike one another. Yes, think about it. We say that an unrestrained person has pleasure, while someone sound-minded is also pleased by that very sound-mindedness. What is more, someone devoid of intelligence and full of stupid opinions and hopes is pleased, and yet the men of understanding take pleasure in that very understanding. Now, how could anyone say that each of these pleasures is like one another and not be regarded, quite rightly, as stupid?

12d

Protarchus: Well, Socrates, although they arrive from opposite things, the pleasures themselves are not opposite to one another. Indeed, how could pleasure not be completely like pleasure, and how could this, of all things, not be like itself?

12e

Socrates: And, indeed, colour, my friend, is like colour. In this respect at any rate, as all being colour, it will not differ. And yet we all realise that black and white are different and happen to be completely opposite. And, of course, shape is like shape on the same basis, and as a class it is all one. However, some of its parts are completely opposite to one another, others have lots of differences, and we shall find numerous other instances of such distinctions. So, do not trust this argument which makes one out of all the complete opposites. No, I am afraid we shall find that some pleasures are the opposite of other pleasures.

13a

Protarchus: Perhaps, but why does that harm my argument?

Socrates: Because I shall maintain that, although they are unlike, you are referring to them by a different name, for you assert that all pleasures are good. Now, no one will put forward the argument that pleasures are not pleasant, but I do say that many are bad while some are good. However, you refer to them all as good, though you agree that they are not alike, if someone compels you to do so in discussion. Well then, what is the same in good and bad pleasures alike, which makes you call all pleasures good?

13b

Protarchus: What are you saying, Socrates? Do you really think that anyone who proposes that the good is pleasure will agree with this, and then tolerate your suggestion that there are some good pleasures but others that are bad?

13c

Socrates: And yet you will state that they are not like one another, and that some are opposites.

Protarchus: But not insofar as they are pleasures.

Socrates: We are carried back again to the same argument, Protarchus, and so we shall say that pleasure is not different

from pleasure, and that all pleasures are alike. The examples we gave just now make no impression upon us, and we go on behaving and talking like the most inept beginners in the conduct of discourse.

13d

Protarchus: What do you mean?

Socrates: That if I copy you, and dare to defend myself by saying that the most unlike is most completely like the most unlike, I shall be forced to say the same thing as you. We shall prove worse than beginners, and our discussion will collapse and come to nought. So, let us work backwards, and perhaps we may be able to come to some agreement with one another by reverting to our original propositions.

Protarchus: How? Tell me.

13e

Socrates: Assume, Protarchus, that I in turn am being questioned by you.

Protarchus: In what way?

Socrates: Take understanding, knowledge, reason, and anything else I proposed at the outset and declared to be good when I asked what good is. Now, does this argument not run into the same problem as yours?

Protarchus: How?

Socrates: All the branches of knowledge taken together will seem numerous, and some of them will seem to be unlike one another. And, indeed, if some turn out somehow to be opposites, would I be a worthy dialectician now if I were to say that knowledge does not become unlike knowledge because I was afraid of that statement about opposites? Wouldn't our discussion then be reduced to nothing, like some, and would we then be saved by something irrational?

14a

Protarchus: No, that simply must not happen, except what you said about being saved. Anyway, the equal treatment of your argument and mine is quite acceptable. Assume there are many pleasures, and let them be unlike; and assume there are many kinds of knowledge, and let them be different.

14b

Socrates: Well, let us not conceal the difference between your concept of the good and mine. We should set them before us for all to see, and be confident that when tested in some way, they may reveal whether we should say that pleasure or understanding, or some third option, is the good. For surely we are not in competition as to whether my views will prevail over yours, or yours over mine. No, somehow we must both strive together for the supreme truth.

Protarchus: Yes, we must.

14c

Socrates: Well, let us make the issue more definite by means of consensus.

Protarchus: What issue do you mean?

Socrates: One which presents a difficulty for everybody, though some meet it willingly, others on occasion unwillingly.

Protarchus: Speak more plainly.

Socrates: I am referring to a natural wonder which has emerged from this discussion. Yes, saying that many things are one, and one is many, is a wonder, and it is easy to argue against anyone who proposes either argument.

14d

Protarchus: Do you mean when someone says that I, Protarchus, am one by nature, and again that there are many of me which are opposite to one another, proposing that the same person is large and small, light and heavy, and so on, endlessly?

Socrates: Protarchus, you have described the more commonplace wonders of the one and the many. But I think most people agree by now not to bother with such instances, appreciating that they are childish, facile and a considerable impediment to the arguments. Nor are we concerned with anyone who uses an argument separating the limbs and the parts of a thing, having secured agreement that they all constitute a single entity, and then argues contemptuously that he has forced us into the monstrous conclusions that the one is many and limitless, and that the many is only one.

14e

Protarchus: Yes, Socrates, but what sort of other wonders are you referring to on this particular issue which are not commonplace and regarded as of no interest?

15a

Socrates: It arises, my boy, when someone proposes a one that is not in the realm of becoming and perishing, as were the examples we were giving just now. Indeed, this sort of one, as we were saying, is agreed to require no scrutiny. On the other hand, if someone attempts to posit man or ox or the beautiful or the good as a one, in the case of these unities and their like, the controversy associated with their division becomes extremely intense.

Protarchus: How?

15b

Socrates: Firstly, over whether we should accept that there are, in truth, units such as these. Then whether we should also accept, somehow, that each of these units – being one, always the same, with no involvement in generation or destruction – is still undeniably this single unit. In which case it is either dispersed among the things which come into being, and which are in turn limitless, or else, though this seems completely impossible, it arises whole, separate from itself, the same and

one, simultaneously present in each and every thing. It is not those other contentions, Protarchus, but contentions about this sort of one and many which are responsible for utter perplexity if not properly resolved, and are responsible for excellent progress if they are.

15c

Protarchus: So, is this the first issue we should tackle now?

Socrates: Well, that is how it seems to me anyway.

Protarchus: Then take it that we shall all go along with you on this. Though perhaps it is best not to ask Philebus right now, and let the sleeping dog lie.

15d

Socrates: Very well, then. Where shall we begin this great and complex dispute about these contentious issues? Ah! What about here?

Protarchus: Where?

Socrates: I think we can say that arguments about the many becoming one and the same are in circulation, in various guises, in everything that is ever said from antiquity to the present day. And this did not begin recently, nor will it ever cease. Rather, it seems to me that this sort of thing is an undying and ageless¹ characteristic of our own discourses. And when any young person first gets a taste of it, he is delighted, as though he had found some treasury of wisdom. He is inspired by pleasure, and loves to set every argument in motion, first rolling it out into its distinctions, and then kneading it into one. Then he rolls it out again and takes it apart, casting himself, first and foremost, into perplexity, followed by any of his usual associates, be they younger, older or the same age, sparing neither father nor mother, nor any other potential listener. And, indeed, he would almost involve the other animals, not only humans, since he would show no mercy even to foreigners, if only an interpreter

were to be found.

16a

Protarchus: Now, Socrates, do you not see how many of us there are, and that we are all young? Are you not afraid in case we join forces with Philebus, and attack you for slandering us? Anyway, we do know what you mean, and if there is any means or contrivance to free our discussion gently from such confusion, and discover some better method than this to approach the argument, please apply yourself to it, Socrates, and we shall follow as best we can. For it is no trivial issue which lies before us.

16b

Socrates: No, it is not, my boys, as Philebus calls you. Well, there is not, nor could there be, a better method than the method whose constant lover I am, though it has often deserted me and left me alone and perplexed.

Protarchus: What is it? Just tell us.

16c

Socrates: It is not a difficult method to describe, but it is extremely difficult to employ. Indeed, anything which has ever been discovered by means of any skill has been made evident through this method. Look, I will describe it.

Protarchus: Yes, describe it.

Socrates: To me, it is evidently a gift to humanity from the gods, hurled from the realm of the gods, along with the brightest fire, by some Prometheus. And the men of old, being superior to us and dwelling closer to the gods, passed on constantly the statement that all of the things which are generally said to be are from one and many, with limit and limitlessness enshrined within them. Now, since this is how they are arranged, we should always assume that there is a single form associated with everything in each case, and we

should search for that, and we shall find that it is there. Then, if we can apprehend it, we should consider two after one, if there is any second, and if not, we should consider three or some other number. And each one of those again in the same manner until we can see that the initial one is not only one, many and limitless, but also how many it is. But we should not apply the form of the limitless to the multiplicity until we can discern its entire number lying between the limitless and the one, and at that stage we may then quite readily allow each one of them to proceed towards the limitless. Now, the gods, as I said, have passed on to us this manner of enquiry, understanding, and teaching one another. But the wise men of today make one and many too quickly or too slowly in a random manner, and after one they go immediately to unlimited, and whatever is in between escapes them. And therein lies the distinction between the dialectical and disputatious approach to our discussions.

17a

Protarchus: I think I understand much of what you are saying, Socrates, but I would still like to hear a clearer explanation of some of it.

Socrates: Well, my meaning is evident, Protarchus, in the case of letters. So, understand it based upon your education in these.

17b

Protarchus: How?

Socrates: Sound which comes through the mouth of each and every person is presumably one. And then again it is also limitless in multiplicity.

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: And we are never wiser on account of one or the other of these, neither because we know the limitless aspect of it nor the single aspect. Rather, what makes each of us literate is knowing the number of sounds and their qualities.

Protarchus: Very true.

Socrates: And, indeed, it is the same thing that makes a musician.

Protarchus: How?

17c

Socrates: Well, the sound associated with this art is also presumably one in itself.

Protarchus: Yes, it must be.

Socrates: However, we would propose that there is a high and low pitch, and a third which is neither. Is this so?

Protarchus: Quite so.

Socrates: But you would never be wise with regard to music if you only knew these. Though if you did not know them, I can safely say that you would in a sense be worthless as a musician.

Protarchus: I would, indeed.

Socrates: Rather, my friend, you would have to understand the numerical extent of the intervals of high and low sound, their quality, and the distinctions between the intervals, and the extent of the combinations which arise from these, combinations which our forefathers discovered and passed on to us, their successors, under the name harmonies. And there are ----- 1 See Iliad viii.539 for this epithet for the gods. Socrates' characterisation of the problem in this way underscores its seriousness. other internal responses arising in the corresponding movements of the body, which are indeed measured numerically, and, accordingly, they say should be called rhythms and measures. And we should also appreciate that all investigation of one and many must be conducted accordingly. So, once you grasp them in this way, then you become wise, and whenever you select another 'one' belonging to anything whatsoever, and investigate it in this way, you

become knowledgeable about that. But taking the limitless aspect of each of the multiplicities will make you a second-rate thinker in every case, devoid of any reputation or esteem, since you have never turned your gaze to number in anything at all.

17e

Protarchus: Philebus, it seems to me anyway that what Socrates said just now is excellent.

18a

Philebus: It seems so to me too. It is excellent in its own right, but why ever has this argument been presented to us now? And with what precise intention?

Socrates: Well, Protarchus, Philebus is right to ask us this question.

Protarchus: He is indeed, so you had better answer him.

Socrates: I shall do that, once I have explained a further detail about these particular issues. Now, if we take any 'one' whatsoever, we are saying that we must not look immediately to its limitless nature, but to some number. And similarly, in the opposite case, when we are compelled to apprehend the limitless first, we must not proceed to the one immediately, but discern a particular number possessing some multiplicity, and from many finish at one. Once more, let us understand what is now being described, based upon the letters of the alphabet.

18b

Protarchus: How?

Socrates: When some god, or even some divine person – the story from Egypt says his name was Theuth² – observed that sound was limitless, he first noticed the vowel sounds in the limitless, which are not one but multiple, and then other sounds which are not vowels, but can be sounded nevertheless, and that there are a number of these also. Thirdly, he distinguished what we now call mutes, and after that he divided the

unsounded mutes until they were single entities, and did the same thing to the vowels and semi-vowels. Once he had understood their number, he gave the additional name 'letter' to each and every one of them. But observing that none of us could learn one of them just by itself without all of them, he went on to devise a bond which is one, and somehow makes them all one, and he said that there was a single skill applicable to them, and he called it grammar.

18d

Philebus: Protarchus, I now understand the interaction of these letters more clearly than the other issues, but to me there is the same defect in the argument as there was a moment ago.

Socrates: Philebus, is it that you don't see the point of all this?

Philebus: Yes. Both Protarchus and I have been trying to see this for some time.

Socrates: Then you have actually been trying to see something that, according to you, has been right in front of you for some time now.

18e

Philebus: How so?

Socrates: Wasn't our discussion from the outset about understanding and pleasure, and which of the two we should choose?

Philebus: Yes, of course.

Socrates: And, indeed, we said that each of them is one.

Philebus: Certainly.

Socrates: Well, this is precisely what the previous argument is asking us. How is each of them one and many? And why are they not limitless immediately, but instead, at some stage, each acquires a particular number before each of them becomes

limitless?

19a

Protarchus: Socrates has faced us with a far from trivial question, Philebus, though I do not understand the circuitous manner in which he led us here. Anyway, please consider which of us should now respond to what is asked. Now, perhaps it is ridiculous, when I have promised faithfully to take your place in the discussion, to give it back to you again because I cannot answer this question. However, I think it would be much more ridiculous if neither of us could answer. So, please consider what we should do, for Socrates seems to me to be asking whether or not there are forms of pleasure, how many there are, and what they are like. He is also asking the same questions about understanding.

19b

Socrates: What you say is very true, dear son of Callias. Yes, our previous discussion showed that if we are unable to do this in the case of anything which is one, like or the same, or in the case of their opposites, none of us will ever be of any value in any subject.

19c

Protarchus: Socrates, it is quite likely that this is so. Now, while it is good for a wise man to know everything, his second-best course seems to lie in not forgetting himself. Well, why do I say this just now? I shall tell you. You granted this audience and your presence to all of us in order to determine what human acquisition is supreme. Indeed, when Philebus said that it is pleasure, enjoyment and delight, and everything of that sort, you disputed this and said that these are not the best. Rather, it is the other things which we are continually recalling, on purpose, in order to test both possibilities side by side in mind. You seem to be proposing that the good, which is really better than pleasure, is reason, knowledge, understanding, skill, and all that is related thereto. These we must acquire, and not those

others. Well, when these two assertions were made and there was a dispute, we threatened, playfully, that we would not let you go home until these discussions had come to an end, and had been duly clarified. You went along with this and made yourself available to us for this purpose. Therefore we are saying now, just like children, that a gift rightly given cannot be taken back. So, please desist from this manner of opposing us in the present discussion.

19e

Socrates: What do you mean?

20a

Protarchus: Casting us into perplexity, and asking questions to which we cannot give you a proper response right now. Indeed, let's not imagine that our aim is to make us all perplexed. Rather, if we prove unable to answer, then you must do so, as that is what you promised. So decide this for yourself. Should the forms of pleasure and of knowledge be distinguished by you, or instead left alone because you are somehow able to clarify the issues under dispute in some other way, and are willing to do so?

20b

Socrates: Well, since you put it like that, I no longer expect anything dreadful, for the phrase "if you are willing" takes away all fear about anything. And besides this, I think that one of the gods has given me a reminder to help us.

Protarchus: A reminder of what?

Socrates: Of certain arguments about pleasure and understanding which I once heard a long time ago, whether in a dream or whilst awake. I now realise that they said that the good was neither of these, but a third entity, different from them and better than both of them. And, indeed, if this were now to become evident to us, then pleasure would be deprived of its victory, since the good would no longer be the same as

pleasure, would it?

20c

Protarchus: Quite so.

Socrates: And as I see it, we shall no longer need this distinction between the forms of pleasure, but that will become even clearer as we go on.

Protarchus: That is very well expressed. Keep discussing it like that.

Socrates: Well, let us agree on a few more little details first.

Protarchus: What sort of details? ----- 2 Theuth was the Egyptian god of the moon, knowledge, wisdom, writing, hieroglyphics, etc. He was often depicted with the head of an ibis.

20d

Socrates: Whether that which holds the rank of good is necessarily perfect or imperfect.

Protarchus: Surely, Socrates, it is the most perfect of all things?

Socrates: What about this? Is the good sufficient?

Protarchus: How could it not be? Yes, in this regard it exceeds everything else there is.

Socrates: Indeed, I believe it is imperative to state that whatever recognises the good, pursues and desires it, and wishes to capture and acquire it for itself, and thinks of nothing else except whatever also achieves good.

Protarchus: It's not possible to contradict that.

20e

Socrates: Well, let us consider the life of pleasure and the life of understanding, and judge them by looking at each on its own.

Protarchus: How do you mean?

Socrates: Let there be no understanding in the life of pleasure, and no pleasure in the life of understanding. For if either of them is the good, it must not stand in further need of anything else at all. And if either of them turns out to be deficient, presumably that is not yet the true good, according to us.

21a

Protarchus: No. How could it be?

Socrates: Now, shall we try testing them out on you?

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Then answer some questions.

Protarchus: Just ask.

Socrates: Protarchus, would you consent to live your entire life enjoying the greatest pleasures?

Protarchus: Yes, why not?

Socrates: And do you think you would still lack something if this life was yours entirely?

Protarchus: Not at all.

Socrates: Are you sure you wouldn't need to understand, reason, and work out what was needed, and that sort of thing?

21b

Protarchus: But why? Surely I would have everything once I had enjoyment.

Socrates: So, if you lived like this, would you always enjoy the utmost pleasure throughout life?

Protarchus: Why not?

Socrates: And yet, without acquiring reason, memory, knowledge and true opinion, you must firstly, I presume, be ignorant of the very fact that you are enjoying or not enjoying, since you are devoid of all understanding.

Protarchus: I must.

21c

Socrates: And, indeed, since you have not acquired memory either, you would be unable to remember what you once enjoyed, and no memory whatsoever would remain of the pleasure you experience in any moment. What's more, when there is enjoyment, you could not form the opinion that you are enjoying something since you have not acquired true opinion. And without calculation, you could not work out what you would enjoy in the future. Your life would not be the life of a man, but of some jellyfish or of sea creatures whose bodies are encased in shells. Are these the facts, or are there alternatives we can consider?

21d

Protarchus: No. How could there be?

Socrates: Well now, do we want a life like that?

Protarchus: This last argument has, for the moment, rendered me totally speechless, Socrates.

Socrates: Let us not give up just yet. We should turn to the life of reason, and consider that.

Protarchus: What sort of life do you mean?

Socrates: It arises if one of us agrees to live in possession of understanding, reason, knowledge and a complete memory of everything, but with no participation, large or small, in pleasure or pain either, but totally devoid of all such experience.

21e

Protarchus: Neither of these lives would ever be attractive to me, Socrates, nor I imagine to anyone else.

22a

Socrates: And what about the composite, Protarchus, a combination formed by mixing the two?

Protarchus: Do you mean a combination of the life of pleasure and the life of reason and understanding?

Socrates: Yes, that's the sort of thing I mean.

Protarchus: Surely everyone would choose that kind of life in preference to the other two. There will be no exceptions.

Socrates: Now, do we understand what the consequence is for the propositions we are discussing?

22b

Protarchus: Yes, certainly. Three lives have been proposed, two of which are not adequate or desirable for man or any other creature.

Socrates: And isn't it obvious at this stage that neither of these two lives actually held the good? If one of them did, it would be adequate and complete and desirable to any plants or animals which were capable of living their entire lives in that way. And if any of us chose any other, his choice would be opposed to the nature of the truly desirable, and it would be made unwillingly, under ignorance or some unfortunate compulsion.

Protarchus: So it seems, anyway.

22c

Socrates: Then, I think we have said enough to show that Philebus' goddess should not be regarded as the same as the good.

Philebus: Yes, Socrates. But your reason is not the good either, since presumably the same objections apply.

Socrates: Perhaps this is so, Philebus, in the case of my reason. But I think it is somehow different for the true and divine reason. Now, I shall not yet claim first place for reason over the combined life, so we must look at second place and decide what to do about that. Indeed, one of us will probably claim that the basis of this combined life is reason, and the other that it is

pleasure, and so, although neither of these two would be the good, perhaps we might appreciate that one of them is the basis of the good. Now, on this issue I would argue more intensely against Philebus, that in the case of this mixed life, the acquisition which renders this life preferable and good – an acquisition which is kindred to it and resembles it – is not pleasure but reason. And on this account, pleasure could never be said to have a true claim to first or second place. No, it is further back than third, if my reasoning is now to be trusted.

22e

Protarchus: Well, Socrates, it seems to me that pleasure has now fallen, as if struck down by your present arguments as it battled for first place. Reason, on the other hand, seems to have acted wisely when it did not claim primacy, for the same thing would have happened to it. But if pleasure were now deprived entirely of second place, it would suffer a disgrace in the eyes of its own lovers, for it would no longer appear quite so beautiful even to them.

23a

Socrates: In that case, is it not better to leave it alone rather than subjecting it to the pain of intense scrutiny and cross-examination?

Protarchus: You are talking nonsense, Socrates.

23b

Socrates: Is that because I am proposing something impossible, namely that pleasure experiences pain?

Protarchus: That's not the only reason. You are also forgetting that none of us will ever let you go until you have brought the discussion of these matters to a conclusion.

Socrates: Oh, dear Protarchus, then a lengthy discussion lies ahead, while the current issue is hardly an easy one either. Indeed, it also appears that we need another means of securing

second place for reason, different weaponry from the previous arguments, though perhaps some will be the same. Is this what we must do?

Protarchus: Yes, we must.

23c

Socrates: But we should try to be careful about where we propose to begin.

Protarchus: What do you mean?

Socrates: Let us divide everything that is now in the universe into two, or better still, if that is alright, into three.

Protarchus: On what basis would you propose to do this?

Socrates: Let us take some elements from our present arguments.

Protarchus: Of what kind?

Socrates: I believe we said that the god revealed the limited, and also the limitless, in things that are.

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

23d

Socrates: Well, let's propose these as two of our forms, and the third combines both of them into one. But it does seem that I am a comical fellow when it comes to defining and enumerating forms.

Protarchus: My goodness, what are you saying?

Socrates: It appears to me that a fourth kind is also required.

Protarchus: Tell us what it is.

Socrates: Note the cause of the commingling of these with one another, and grant me that as the fourth in addition to the other three.

Protarchus: Would you not also need a fifth element which is able to separate them?

Socrates: Perhaps, but I do not think we actually need it right now. However, I presume you will forgive me if I do go after a fifth kind, should that prove necessary.

23e

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: Well then, having first separated three of the four, and noted that two of these are each multiple as they are split up and dispersed, let us make each of them one again, and try to understand how each was ever both one and many.

Protarchus: If you could tell me about them a little more clearly, perhaps I might follow you.

24a

Socrates: Well, I mean that the two which I am proposing are the same as the two we mentioned just now – the limitless and that which has limit – and I shall try to explain that the limitless is, in some way, many. That which has limit can wait.

Protarchus: Yes, let it wait.

Socrates: Now, think about this. Indeed, what I am asking you to consider is controversial and difficult, but consider it nevertheless. First ask whether you could ever discern any limit to hotter and colder, or whether the greater and the lesser which resides within these kinds themselves would never allow any end to come about, as long as more and less are present. Indeed, if an end were to come about, the more and less would be finished.

24b

Protarchus: What you say is very true.

Socrates: However, we say that both the greater and the lesser are always present in the hotter and the colder.

Protarchus: Very much so.

Socrates: Then our argument shows that these two are always without an end. And surely, since they have no end, they are entirely limitless.

Protarchus: Yes, it shows that quite strongly, Socrates.

24c

Socrates: Now, you have answered very well, dear Protarchus, and have reminded me that the word strongly, which you have just uttered, and the word weakly, have the same force as 'more' and 'less'. Indeed, wherever they are present they do not allow a specific quantity to exist, but they always make activities stronger rather than weaker, or the other way around, and give rise to more and to less, but they eliminate specific quantity. For as we just said, if they did not eliminate quantity, but allowed quantity and measure to arise where greater, lesser, stronger and weaker are situated, these classes themselves would disappear from the very positions they occupied. Indeed, they would no longer be hotter or colder once they had acquired quantity, for hotter is constantly advancing and does not stand still, and the same applies to colder. But quantity is fixed and has stopped advancing. So, based upon this argument, hotter, and its opposite too, turn out to be limitless.

24d

Protarchus: So it appears anyway, Socrates. But as you say, this is not easy to follow. And perhaps going over it again and again may demonstrate that questioner and respondent are in quite close agreement.

24e

Socrates: Yes, that is a good suggestion, and we should try to do that. But first consider whether we shall accept a particular characteristic of the nature of the limitless, so that we do not make the discussion too lengthy and detailed.

Protarchus: What sort of characteristic do you mean?

Socrates: Whatever appears to us to become more and less, or involves strength and mildness, or excess and everything of that sort, should all be placed in the limitless as though it were a single kind. This is based on our previous argument that whatever is split up and dispersed should be brought together, and its single nature indicated, as best we can. Do you remember?

25a

Protarchus: I remember.

Socrates: Again, whatever does not involve these but involves all their opposites – first, the equal and equality, and after the equal, the double, and any relation of number to number or measure to measure – all of these should be counted among the limited. This would appear to be our best approach. What do you think?

25b

Protarchus: Yes, very properly, Socrates.

Socrates: Very well. But what about the third kind, the mixture of these two? What characteristic shall we say that this possesses?

Protarchus: I think you are also going to answer that question for me.

Socrates: A god will certainly answer, if one of the gods happens to hear my prayers.

Protarchus: Then pray, and watch.

Socrates: I am watching, Protarchus, and it seems to me that one of them has befriended us just now.

25c

Protarchus: What do you mean? And what evidence have you?

Socrates: I shall answer of course, but please follow my argument.

Protarchus: Just speak.

Socrates: We described something as hotter and colder just now. Is this so?

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: Now add drier and wetter to these, also greater and lesser, faster and slower, larger and smaller, and whatever we previously included in the single nature which involves more and less.

25d

Protarchus: Do you mean the nature which is limitless?

Socrates: Yes. And combine this in turn with the offspring of the limited.

Protarchus: What offspring?

Socrates: I am referring to the nature of the limited, which we should also have drawn into a unity just now, just as we did with the limitless. We did not do so, but perhaps we shall get the same result, if the latter nature is made evident by drawing the other two into a unity.

Protarchus: What nature? What do you mean?

Socrates: The nature which contains equal and double, and whatever prevents opposites from differing from one another, and renders them symmetric and harmonious by introducing number.

25e

Protarchus: I understand. I think you mean that when these are mixed, certain products arise as a consequence in each case.

Socrates: Yes, your understanding is correct.

Protarchus: Keep going.

Socrates: Well, in the case of disease, doesn't the proper combining of these opposites produce a healthy nature?

26a

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And in the case of high and low pitch, and fast and slow, which are limitless, the same products arise. And once limit is brought about, the combinations establish all of music in perfection. Is this so?

Protarchus: Absolutely.

Socrates: And, indeed, if the combinations arise where there is cold or heat, having removed the excessive and limitless, they at the same time brought about measure and symmetry.

Protarchus: Yes, indeed.

26b

Socrates: Don't the seasons and all the other beauties of our world arise from this commingling of the limitless with whatever has limit?

Protarchus: It must be so.

Socrates: Yes. And there are countless other instances which I omit mentioning, such as beauty and strength in addition to health, and also the countless different and varied beauties of the soul. For this goddess, noble Philebus, beholding for herself the insolence and general vice of everyone without any limit on the pleasure or gratification among them, introduced law and order, which do possess limit. You may say that she afflicted us, but I would say the opposite. She saved us. Is this how it seems to you, Protarchus?

26c

Protarchus: Socrates, this is very much to my way of thinking.

Socrates: Well, you may notice that I have now described these three.

Protarchus: Yes, I think I can see that. Indeed, you seem to be saying that the limitless is one, and the limit in things is second and is also one. However, I do not quite understand what you wish to designate as third.

Socrates: Yes, no wonder. The sheer scale of the third class has overwhelmed you. However, the limitless class also demonstrated multiplicity, and yet it turned out to be one, as it was stamped with the mark of the class of more, and its opposite.

26d

Protarchus: True.

Socrates: Nor indeed did we make difficulties by saying that the limited neither involved multiplicity, nor was it one by nature.

Protarchus: No, why would we?

Socrates: There is no reason at all. But assume that I regard the third as the entire offspring of the other two, taken as one, a product brought into being from the measures which are generated along with the limited.

Protarchus: I understand.

26e

Socrates: Well now, besides these three we should also consider the fourth class we mentioned earlier. Let's share the enquiry. Ask yourself whether it is necessary that everything which comes into being is generated because of some cause.

Protarchus: I think so, for how could it come into being without a cause?

Socrates: But doesn't the nature of the maker differ from the cause in nothing except its name, and should the maker and the

cause properly be described as one?

Protarchus: Correct.

27a

Socrates: And, indeed, we shall also find that what is made is, in turn, different in nothing except name from ‘what comes into being’. Is this so?

Protarchus: It is so.

Socrates: Now, isn’t it natural that the maker always leads, while what is made follows that by coming into being?

Protarchus: Certainly.

Socrates: So, the cause, and whatever serves the cause in the productive process, are different and not the same.

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: Therefore, whatever comes into being and whatever everything arises from provide us with the three classes.

Protarchus: They do, indeed.

27b

Socrates: And, indeed, we say that the fourth which produces all these is the cause, since we have adequately demonstrated that it is different from them.

Protarchus: Yes, it is different.

Socrates: Well, now that the four have been distinguished, it is a good idea to list them in sequence as a reminder of each one.

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: Then I place the limitless first, the limited second, and the mixed-being produced from these, third. And would it be a mistake to say that the cause of the mixing and production is the fourth?

27c

Protarchus: No, how could it be?

Socrates: Well then, what is our next topic of discussion, and what consideration brought us to these issues? Wasn't it this? We were deciding whether the second-best life should consist of pleasure or understanding. Wasn't that it?

Protarchus: Yes, that was it.

Socrates: However, since we have now made this four-fold distinction, perhaps we may be better able to finalise the decision about first and second place, which was of course the first issue we disagreed about.

Protarchus: Perhaps.

27d

Socrates: So come on, we awarded the victory to the mixed life of pleasure and understanding. Is this what we did?

Protarchus: It was.

Socrates: Shouldn't we look at this life and what it is, and which class it belongs to?

Protarchus: Why not?

Socrates: And we shall say, I presume, that it is part of the third class, for this does not consist of just two elements, but of the sum of all that is limitless, bound by limit. On this basis it is appropriate that this victorious mixed life should be part of that category.

Protarchus: Yes, you are quite right.

27e

Socrates: Very well. But, Philebus, what about your life of pleasure which is unmixed? In which of the classes we mentioned should it properly be included? But before you tell us, let me ask this question.

Philebus: Just ask.

Socrates: Do pleasure and pain have limit, or are they in the class involving both more and less?

Philebus: Yes, pleasure involves more, Socrates, for it would not be entirely good unless it happened by nature to be limitless in extent and in intensity.

28a

Socrates: Nor would pain be entirely bad, Philebus, so we should look for something other than the limitless nature of pleasure, in order to furnish it with some part of good. So you may include these two among the classes of limitless things. But, Protarchus and Philebus, into which of the classes we mentioned may we now, without impiety, place understanding, knowledge and reason? Yes, I think there is a lot at stake if we do not get the answer to this question right.

28b

Philebus: Now you are exalting your own god, Socrates.

Socrates: Yes, and you are exalting your own goddess, my friend. Nevertheless, the question must be answered.

Protarchus: What Socrates is saying to you is right, Philebus, and you should do as he says.

Philebus: Didn't you volunteer to speak on my behalf, Protarchus?

Protarchus: I did, indeed. But now I am a bit perplexed, Socrates, and I need you yourself to act as our spokesman, so that we don't miss the point and make some inappropriate statement about your contestant for second place.

28c

Socrates: I should do as you say, Protarchus, as you are not making a difficult request. But did I really upset you with that playful exaltation, as Philebus calls it, when I asked what sort of class reason and knowledge should be in?

Protarchus: You certainly did, Socrates.

Socrates: Anyway, it is easy to answer, for all of the wise concur, in genuine self-exaltation, that reason is our lord of heaven and earth. And perhaps they are right. But we may carry out a more lengthy investigation of the class itself, if you wish.

28d

Protarchus: Proceed as you wish, Socrates! Regardless of the length, you will not bore us.

Socrates: Well said! Let us begin by repeating this question.

Protarchus: What question?

Socrates: Whether we should say, Protarchus, that this so-called universe and everything else is ruled by an irrational and random power, and that things happen by chance, or conversely as our predecessors said, that it is governed by reason and ordered by a wonderful understanding.

28e

Protarchus: It's you, Socrates, who is wonderful. But the two accounts have nothing in common. I see the first option sounds quite irreverent to me. However, the statement that reason brings order to everything is worthy of the ordered vision of the universe, and sun, moon and stars, and the revolving heavens, and I myself would never say nor even think anything else about them.

29a

Socrates: Well, is this what you want? Should we agree with our predecessors and join them in declaring that these things are so, not merely speaking the words of others in safety, but sharing the danger and partaking of the abuse whenever a clever man says that the universe is not ordered like this, but is disordered?

Protarchus: Yes. What else could I want?

Socrates: Then come on and think about the argument we are facing here.

Protarchus: Please explain.

Socrates: I presume we realise that fire, water, air and earth – which storm-battered sailors call land – are involved in the formation of the physical nature of all creatures.

29b

Protarchus: Very much so, and we are truly being battered by the perplexities of the current argument.

Socrates: Now, there is something you should understand about these constituents of our nature.

Protarchus: What is it?

Socrates: That the portion of each of these elements in us is small, mundane, and not at all pure, and does not possess the power worthy of its nature. Let's take a single example, but it is the same for them all. For instance, there is fire in us and also fire in the universe.

Protarchus: Of course.

29c

Socrates: Now, the portion in us is small, weak and insignificant, while the fire in the universe is wondrous in extent, in beauty, and all the power associated with fire.

Protarchus: Yes. What you say is very true.

Socrates: Well then, is the universal fire sustained, given existence and augmented by the fire within us? Or is it the other way around, that the fire in you and in me and in the other creatures derives everything from the universal?

Protarchus: This question is not even worthy of a reply.

29d

Socrates: Correct. And I imagine you will say the same thing about the earth which is here in the creatures and the earth in the universe, and will answer likewise in the case of all of the other elements I asked you about a little earlier. Would you reply in this way?

Protarchus: Well, could anyone answer differently and still appear sane?

Socrates: Hardly anyone at all. But follow this next point. When we see all the elements we mentioned combined into one, don't we call it a body?

Protarchus: Of course.

29e

Socrates: Now, understand that the same applies to what we call the universe, which is composed of the same elements and would, therefore, I suppose, be a body on the same basis.

Protarchus: Absolutely correct.

Socrates: And are our bodies sustained by this body, or is it sustained by ours? And has it acquired and does it possess whatever we ascribed to them just now?

Protarchus: That, Socrates, is another question which is not worth asking.

30a

Socrates: Well then, is this next question worth asking? What do you think?

Protarchus: What is the question?

Socrates: Wouldn't we say that our body has a soul?

Protarchus: Obviously we would.

Socrates: But where, my dear Protarchus, did it get it, unless the body of the universe – a body which has the same as our body but in far greater beauty – is also ensouled?

Protarchus: Obviously there is nowhere else it could come from, Socrates.

Socrates: Now, Protarchus, in the case of the four classes – limit, limitless, their combination and the causal class – I presume we realise that this fourth, present in everything, furnishing us with soul, producing regimen and exercise for the body when it falls ill, is called extensive and multifaceted wisdom when we hear of it in other instances. But do we believe that when these same four are present in the whole universe on a large scale, and, what is more, in greater beauty and purity, this wisdom would fail to generate a beautiful and hallowed nature among them?

30c

Protarchus: That would not be at all reasonable.

Socrates: Well, if that is invalid, we had better go with the other account which suggests, as we have often said, that there is extensive limitlessness in the universe, sufficient limit, and an extraordinary cause which governs them, ordering and arranging the years, seasons and months, which may rightly be referred to as wisdom and reason.

Protarchus: Rightly so, indeed.

Socrates: But there could never be wisdom and reason without soul.

Protarchus: There could not.

30d

Socrates: Then, you will say that there is a lordly soul in the nature of Zeus, and lordly reason is engendered through the power of the cause, while in other gods there are other glories, and each of them likes to be described accordingly.

Protarchus: Very much so.

Socrates: Now, Protarchus, do not imagine that this statement we have made is some trifle. No, it lends support to those people of old who said that reason always rules the universe.

Protarchus: Yes, it does indeed.

Socrates: And, in fact, it has provided an answer to my query, by saying that of the four classes, reason belongs to the one which we referred to as the cause of everything. I presume that you have got our answer to the question at this stage.

30e

Protarchus: Yes I have, and it is most satisfactory, though I did not realise you were answering me.

Socrates: Indeed, Protarchus, playfulness sometimes brings relief from seriousness.

Protarchus: Well put.

31a

Socrates: Surely, my friend, we have now explained quite plausibly the class to which reason belongs, and the power it possesses.

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And, indeed, the class to which pleasure belongs was evident in like manner some time ago.

Protarchus: Very much so.

Socrates: So, let us also recall some facts about both. Reason was akin to a cause, and fitted that class quite well, while pleasure itself was limitless, and belonged in the class which does not possess beginning, middle or end within itself, from itself, nor will ever do so.

31b

Protarchus: We shall remember. Indeed, how could we forget?

Socrates: Now, the next thing we need to do is see what each of them reside in, and what condition causes them to arise when they do arise. Let us take pleasure first since we examined its class first. Let us do the same with these questions. However, we could never examine pleasure adequately in isolation from pain.

Protarchus: Well, if it is necessary to proceed in that way, let's proceed in that way.

Socrates: Does the generation of these appear to you as it does to me?

31c

Protarchus: How is that?

Socrates: It appears to me that, by nature, pleasure and pain both arise at the same time in the combined class.

Protarchus: But Socrates, my friend, please remind us which of the four classes, from our earlier discussion, you wish to designate as 'combined'.

Socrates: Well, you're a wonder! I'll do the best I can.

Protarchus: Well said.

Socrates: Well, we should regard the 'combined' as the third of the classes we mentioned.

Protarchus: Is it the one you listed after the limitless and limit, and in which, I think, you placed health and harmony?

Socrates: Excellent! Now give me your closest attention.

Protarchus: Speak on.

31d

Socrates: Then, I claim that when harmony is disrupted in us living creatures, then a disruption of our natural state and a generation of pain arise at the same time.

Protarchus: Quite likely.

Socrates: But if harmony is again restored and it returns to its own nature, we should say that pleasure arises, if we must speak on a vast subject briefly and most hastily.

31e

Protarchus: I do think that what you are saying is correct, Socrates, but let's try to describe these particular issues more clearly.

Socrates: Aren't the commonplace and obvious instances somehow easiest to understand?

Protarchus: What instances?

Socrates: Is hunger, in a sense, a disruption and a pain?

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: And is eating, and being filled once more, a pleasure?

Protarchus: Yes.

32a

Socrates: Thirst, for its part, is a disturbance and a pain, while pleasure is the ability of a liquid to replenish what has dried out. Again, the unnatural dispersal and dissolution which are the effects of heat is a pain, while the natural restoration and cooling is a pleasure.

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Also, the unnatural congealing of the fluids in a creature due to cold is a pain, whereas their dispersal and return to their former state, the natural course, is a pleasure. And in short, consider whether it would be reasonable for someone to say that when the natural form of limit and limitless, which as we said earlier constitutes an ensouled being, is disrupted, this disruption is a pain, while the restoration of them all once more, back to the course of their own being, is a pleasure.

32b

Protarchus: Good. That sounds to me like a fair summary.

Socrates: Then, may we propose that either of these experiences constitutes one form of pleasure and of pain?

Protarchus: We may.

32c

Socrates: Also, let us propose that there is expectation of these experiences by the soul itself, the sweet and confident anticipation prior to the pleasures, and the fear and anxiety prior to the pains.

Protarchus: Yes, and this is a different form of pleasure and pain, which arises in the soul itself independently of the body, through anticipation.

Socrates: Your understanding is correct. For in these instances, in my opinion, I believe that each arises in a pure form, and seemingly are not mixtures of pleasure and pain. So, it will be evident, in the case of pleasure, whether the entire class is desirable, or whether we should say this about one of the other classes we mentioned, rather than about pleasure and pain. In which case, pleasure and pain, just like hot and cold and everything of that sort, should sometimes be desired and sometimes not, as they are not actually good, though some of them, on occasion, assume the nature of things that are good at the time.

32d

Protarchus: You are quite right to say that we should work through the difficulty we are now pursuing in this sort of manner.

32e

Socrates: Well, let's agree on something first, that if what was said is indeed the case, and pain is disruptive while pleasure is restorative, we should also reflect upon the absence of

disruption and restoration, and the precise state of each living creature under such circumstances. Think hard about this, and then respond. Isn't it inescapable that the creature, at that particular time, experiences neither pleasure nor pain to any degree?

Protarchus: Yes, it must be so.

33a

Socrates: Isn't such a condition a third option for us besides those of pleasure and pain?

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: Well, try to remember this as we proceed, for it is quite significant for our decision about pleasure whether we remember this or not. And we should say a little more about it if you have no objection.

Protarchus: Tell me.

Socrates: Note that there is nothing to prevent someone, who has chosen the life of understanding, from living in this manner.

33b

Protarchus: Do you mean living without either pleasure or pain?

Socrates: Yes. For it was stated, I believe, in the comparison of lives, that the person who chooses the life of reason and understanding must not experience pleasure to any degree.

Protarchus: Yes, that is certainly what was said.

Socrates: Therefore, he would live like this, and it would not be surprising if it proved to be the most divine of the lives.

Protarchus: Yes, as it is quite unlikely that the gods experience either pleasure or its opposite.

Socrates: Most unlikely indeed, as it would be quite unbecoming for them to experience either. However, we shall consider this again later, if it is relevant to our discussion, and we shall add it to the evidence that reason should have second place, if we cannot do so for first place.

33c

Protarchus: A very appropriate suggestion.

Socrates: And, indeed, the other form of pleasure, which we said belongs to the soul itself, comes into being entirely through memory.

Protarchus: How?

Socrates: It seems we must first understand what precisely memory is, and may even have to understand perception before memory, if all of these related issues are to become clearer to us in an appropriate manner.

33d

Protarchus: How do you mean?

Socrates: Take the case of the experiences of our body. Some of these are extinguished within the body before they arrive at the soul, leaving soul unaffected, while others proceed through both body and soul, engendering a sort of vibration which is particular to each but common to both.

Protarchus: Very well.

Socrates: Now, in the case where the experiences do not proceed through both body and soul, would we say that the soul is unaware, while, on the other hand, when they do involve both, shall we be quite right to say that it is not unaware?

33e

Protarchus: This must be so.

Socrates: However, you should certainly not assume that I am saying that the unawareness somehow produces forgetfulness

in this case. Indeed, forgetfulness is the departure of a memory, which in the case we are describing has not yet arisen. And it would be strange to speak of the loss of something which is not, and has not yet come into existence. Is that so?

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: Then you should just change the names.

Protarchus: In what way?

Socrates: Rather than saying that the soul is ‘unaware’ when it is not affected by the vibrations associated with the body, let’s use the term ‘insensible’ for what we now call forgetting.

34a

Protarchus: I understand.

Socrates: On the other hand, the coming together of body and soul in a single experience, where they are also moved together, is a movement which, for its part, could appropriately be referred to by the name ‘perception’.

Protarchus: Very true.

Socrates: So, do we now understand what we mean when we use the term perception?

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: So, anyone who says that memory is the preservation of perception would, in my view, be quite right to say so.

34b

Protarchus: Yes, correct indeed.

Socrates: And don’t we say that recollection is different from memory?

Protarchus: Perhaps.

Socrates: Are they not different in the following way?

Protarchus: What way?

Socrates: When the soul itself, without use of the body, retrieves within itself as best it can whatever it once experienced along with the body, presumably we say that it is then recollecting. Is this so?

Protarchus: It certainly is.

Socrates: And, indeed, when memory of either a perception or piece of knowledge has been lost, and the soul itself digs it up again within itself all these occurrences are also called recollections, I presume.

34c

Protarchus: You are right.

Socrates: Now, the reason we have said all this is as follows.

Protarchus: Tell me.

Socrates: So that we may understand the pleasure of the soul without body as comprehensively and clearly as we can, and also its desire at the same time. Indeed, through these two it seems that both will be clarified.

Protarchus: In that case, Socrates, we should discuss them next.

Socrates: It seems that our investigation must involve a lot of discussion about the origin of pleasure and every form it has, and, indeed, it appears the first thing we must understand is what desire is and where it arises.

34d

Protarchus: Then let's investigate it, for we have nothing to lose.

Socrates: We do have something to lose, Protarchus. If we find what we are now looking for, we lose our perplexity about these very matters.

Protarchus: You are right to remind us, but now let's try to address the next issues.

34e

Socrates: Didn't we say just now that hunger and thirst, and numerous other things of that sort, were desires?

Protarchus: Most definitely.

Socrates: So, what precisely is the sameness we look to, whereby we call them by one name though they differ so much?

Protarchus: By Zeus, Socrates, that question may not be easy to answer, but it deserves a response nonetheless.

Socrates: Then let's resume the discussion again from there, based on the same examples.

Protarchus: From where?

Socrates: We say, do we not, that someone is thirsty?

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: And does this mean that he is empty of something?

Protarchus: Indeed.

Socrates: Now, is thirst a desire?

Protarchus: Yes, a desire for drink.

35a

Socrates: For drink, or satisfaction through drink?

Protarchus: I think it is for satisfaction.

Socrates: So, when one of us is empty, it seems that he desires the opposite of whatever he experiences, for being empty he desires satisfaction.

Protarchus: Obviously.

Socrates: What about this? When we are empty for the first time, is there any way we can have contact with satisfaction,

either through perception or through memory, when we have no present experience of satisfaction, and have never experienced it before?

Protarchus: No, how could we?

35b

Socrates: And yet we say that whoever is desiring, desires something.

Protarchus: It must be so.

Socrates: So he does not desire that which he is experiencing, for he is thirsty and this is an emptiness, but his desire is for satisfaction.

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: Therefore, some aspect of the thirsty person would somehow have contact with satisfaction.

Protarchus: It must.

Socrates: However, it cannot be the body, for it is presumably empty.

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: The only other option is that the soul would have contact with satisfaction, obviously through memory, for how else could it have contact with it?

35c

Protarchus: There is hardly any alternative.

Socrates: Do we understand what consequences these arguments have for us?

Protarchus: What are they?

Socrates: This argument is telling us that desire belonging to the body does not arise.

Protarchus: In what way?

Socrates: Because it reveals that every creature consistently strives for the opposite of what it is experiencing.

Protarchus: Very much so.

Socrates: But the urge leading towards the opposite of what is being experienced would presumably make it clear that there is memory of those opposite experiences.

Protarchus: Very much so.

35d

Socrates: So, having shown that memory is what impels us towards objects of desire, the argument has demonstrated that every urge and desire, and the motive principle of the entire creature, belongs to soul.

Protarchus: Correct.

Socrates: Therefore, the argument will not accept that our body experiences thirst or hunger or anything of that sort.

Protarchus: Very true.

Socrates: Now, there is something else we should observe about these same examples. Indeed, the argument seems to want to show us that a certain mode of life is implied in these particular cases.

35e

Protarchus: In what cases, and to what sort of life are you referring?

Socrates: I mean cases where there is satisfaction and deficiency, and whatever else is associated with the preservation or destruction of living beings. When one of us encounters either process, he experiences either pain or pleasure, depending on the transformation.

Protarchus: Yes, that is what happens.

Socrates: And what happens if we are in between the two conditions?

Protarchus: How?

Socrates: When someone is pained by an experience, and remembers the pleasures which would stop the pain but is not yet satisfied, what about that? Shall we say that he is in between the two conditions, or shall we not?

36a

Protarchus: Let's say that he is.

Socrates: Is he experiencing complete pleasure or complete pain?

Protarchus: Not pleasure, by Zeus. Instead he is afflicted by a twofold pain, one based upon what the body is experiencing, the other based upon the soul's anticipation and longing.

Socrates: Protarchus, how can you say that the pain is twofold? Is it not the case that sometimes when we lack something we stand in evident hope of being satisfied, while at other times, on the contrary, we have no hope?

36b

Protarchus: Yes, very much so.

Socrates: Don't you think that we are pleased by the memory when there is hope of being satisfied, even though there is also deficiency and we are in pain at that time?

Protarchus: This must be so.

Socrates: On such an occasion, man and the other creatures experience both pleasure and pain simultaneously.

Protarchus: Quite likely.

Socrates: But what if he is empty, with no hope of attaining satisfaction? Isn't that when the twofold affliction would arise over the painful experience which you considered just now,

when you expressed the view that the pain is always twofold?

36c

Protarchus: That is very true, Socrates.

Socrates: Now, let us make some use of this investigation into these experiences in the following way.

Protarchus: In what way?

Socrates: Should we declare that these pains and pleasures are true, or that they are false? Or are some true and others not?

Protarchus: But Socrates, how could pleasures or pains be false?

Socrates: But Protarchus, how could there be true or false fears, or expectations which are true or untrue, or true and false opinions?

36d

Protarchus: Well, I would agree with you about the opinions, but not the others.

Socrates: Do you realise what you are saying? It is very likely that we are initiating a significant discussion.

Protarchus: That's true.

Socrates: Son of a great man! But if it is relevant to what has been said before, we should consider this.

Protarchus: Perhaps, in this case anyway.

Socrates: Then we must forgo any lengthy digression or irrelevant discussions.

Protarchus: Correct.

36e

Socrates: So, discuss this with me, for the very perplexities we presented just now are a source of constant wonder to me. What have you to say? Are there not false as well as true pleasures?

Protarchus: How could there be?

Socrates: In that case, you are saying that no one in a dream or awake, in madness or mental disorder, ever presumes that he is experiencing pleasure when he is not experiencing pleasure, or, on the other hand, presumes that he is experiencing pain when he is not experiencing pain.

Protarchus: Socrates, we all presume that these things do happen.

Socrates: But are we right to presume so or should we consider whether this is correct or incorrect?

Protarchus: I'd say we should consider this.

37a

Socrates: Then let us be more precise and clear in discussing pleasure and opinion. Indeed, we do have the power to form opinions, I presume?

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: And to experience pleasure?

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: And, indeed, is there also an object of opinion?

Protarchus: How could there not be?

Socrates: And is there something by which the enjoyer is pleased?

Protarchus: Again, there must be.

Socrates: Now, whether the one who forms opinions forms them correctly or incorrectly, the actual opinion forming is never lost.

37b

Protarchus: No, how could it?

Socrates: And again, whether the enjoyer enjoys correctly or incorrectly, obviously he will never lose the actual enjoying.

Protarchus: Yes, that is also the case.

Socrates: Therefore, we must consider how it comes about that opinion can be either true or false, while pleasure is only true. And yet, the opinion forming and the enjoying are both alike designated as actual.

Protarchus: We should consider this.

37c

Socrates: True and false are applicable to opinion, and on that account it becomes not just opinion, but opinion with one of these qualities. Is this what you say we should consider?

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: But, besides this, we also need to agree whether in general there are things which have qualities, while on the other hand pleasure and pain are just as they are and do not take on any qualities.

Protarchus: Obviously.

Socrates: But it is not hard to see that these two have qualities. For we said a while ago that pleasures and pains can become great or small in varying degrees of intensity.

37d

Protarchus: We certainly did.

Socrates: And yet, Protarchus, if some badness attaches to any of these, shall we say that the opinion becomes bad in this way, and the pleasure also becomes bad?

Protarchus: But of course, Socrates.

Socrates: And what if correctness or the opposite of correctness attaches to any of these? Won't we say that the opinion is correct if it possesses correctness, and that the same

goes for pleasure?

Protarchus: We must.

37e

Socrates: But if the formation of the opinion involves an error, then the opinion involves an error, and we must agree that it is not correct, and is not being correctly formed.

Protarchus: Yes, how could it be?

Socrates: Then again, if we discern that pain or pleasure involve an error about the object which pains or pleases, should we refer to them as correct, or useful, or apply any other term of praise?

Protarchus: No, we should not, if pleasure can actually be in error.

Socrates: And, indeed, it seems anyway that pleasure often arises in us in conjunction with false opinion rather than correct opinion.

38a

Protarchus: Yes, of course, Socrates. But in that case, it is the opinion which we then call false, but no one would ever refer to the pleasure itself as false.

Socrates: Protarchus, you are putting up a brave defence with your current statement about pleasure.

Protarchus: Not really. I'm just reporting what I hear.

Socrates: But, my friend, is there no difference for us between the pleasure accompanied by correct opinion and knowledge, and the pleasure accompanied by false opinion and ignorance which frequently arises in each of us?

38b

Protarchus: There is probably a significant difference.

Socrates: Then let's proceed to contemplate the difference between them.

Protarchus: Proceed as you see fit.

Socrates: Then I shall proceed in a particular way.

Protarchus: What way?

Socrates: Do we say that our opinion is sometimes true, sometimes false?

Protarchus: It is.

Socrates: And as we said, pleasure and pain often follow these – follow true and false opinion I mean.

Protarchus: Certainly.

Socrates: Don't opinion, and the attempt to form definite opinions, always arise in us, in each case, from memory and perception?

38c

Protarchus: Very much so.

Socrates: Now, do we believe that the following example must be relevant in these cases?

Protarchus: What example?

Socrates: Would you agree that often, when someone happens to see things from a distance, not very clearly, he will want to decide what the objects he is looking at actually are?

Protarchus: I would agree.

Socrates: And wouldn't he go on to a particular question?

Protarchus: Such as?

38d

Socrates: "What exactly is it that appears to be situated beside that rock under a tree?" Do you think he might say that to

himself, when presented with appearances of that nature?

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And after this, as an answer to such a question, might he say that it is a man, and be correct in his assertion?

Protarchus: Absolutely.

Socrates: And if he makes a mistake, he might say instead that he is looking at a statue, the work of some shepherds.

Protarchus: Very much so.

Socrates: And if someone was with him, he might repeat once more, out loud to his companion, the very words he had spoken to himself. And in this way, what we previously called an opinion would then become a statement.

Protarchus: Of course.

38e

Socrates: However, if he is alone, he thinks the same thing to himself and sometimes proceeds for a considerable time with that idea in mind.

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Well, I wonder if your view of these situations is like mine.

Protarchus: What is yours like?

Socrates: It seems to me that our soul is then like a book.

Protarchus: How so?

39a

Socrates: When memory coincides with the perceptions and the experiences which are associated with them, they almost seem to me then, in a way, to write words in our souls. And when the truth is written, it results in the generation of true opinion and true arguments within us. However, when our

so-called internal scribe writes what is false, it results in the opposite of true opinions and arguments.

39b

Protarchus: Yes, that is how it seems to me, and I accept this manner of describing it.

Socrates: Then you should also accept that another craftsman arises in our souls at the same time.

Protarchus: Who is he?

Socrates: A painter, who is beside the writer of whatever is said, drawing images of this in the soul.

Protarchus: Yes, but how do we say he does this, and when?

Socrates: It occurs when a person has derived opinions and formulations from sight or some other sense perception, and then somehow beholds images of the opinions and formulations within himself. Doesn't this happen to us?

39c

Protarchus: It certainly does.

Socrates: And aren't the images of the true opinions and formulations true, while the images of the false ones are false?

Protarchus: Entirely so.

Socrates: Now, if we have described this correctly, there is an additional point we must consider.

Protarchus: What is it?

Socrates: Whether this is how we must experience the present or the past events, but not, however, the future events.

Protarchus: Surely it applies to all divisions of time.

39d

Socrates: Wasn't it stated earlier that pleasures and pains arising from the soul itself may come into being before

pleasures and pains arising from the body? As a consequence, anticipated pleasures and pains about the future arise in us.

Protarchus: Very true.

Socrates: Now, we proposed a little earlier that writings and drawings are produced within us. But do these relate only to past and present time, and not to the future?

39e

Protarchus: They definitely relate to the future.

Socrates: So, are you stating emphatically that all these are hopes for the future, and that we, for our part, are always full of hopes throughout our entire life?

Protarchus: Entirely so.

Socrates: Come now, I have a further question from what we have just said.

Protarchus: What is it?

Socrates: Isn't a just and holy and entirely good man also divinely favoured?

Protarchus: Of course.

40a

Socrates: And what about an unjust and utterly bad man? Isn't he in the opposite case?

Protarchus: He must be.

Socrates: Now, every man, as we said earlier, is full of many hopes.

Protarchus: How could he avoid it?

Socrates: Then there are accounts in each of us which we call hopes.

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: And what is more, there are the painted images, and a person may often see himself acquiring a huge quantity of gold and a great deal of pleasure on that account. And in this picture he sees himself absolutely delighted with himself.

40b

Protarchus: Inevitably.

Socrates: Now, should we say that the pictures presented to the good people are generally true, due to the divine favour, while the opposite sort are generally presented to the bad people? Should we say this or not?

Protarchus: We certainly should say this.

Socrates: Therefore, the bad people also have just as many pleasures depicted within, but presumably the pleasures are false.

Protarchus: Of course.

40c

Socrates: So the bad people delight for the most part in false pleasures, while the good people delight in the true.

Protarchus: What you say is most compelling.

Socrates: Then, based upon the present argument, there are false pleasures in people's souls, though they imitate the true pleasures in a ridiculous manner, and the same also applies to pains.

Protarchus: There are.

Socrates: Now, it was shown that it is always possible for someone who forms any opinion actually to form that opinion even though it is sometimes based neither upon the present, the past or the future.

Protarchus: Very much so.

40d

Socrates: And these were, I believe, responsible for false opinions and their formation. Is this so?

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: Well now, shouldn't we also assign to pleasure and pain a condition corresponding to these?

Protarchus: In what way?

Socrates: In the sense that it is always possible for someone who enjoys any pleasure, however unreasonable, to have actual enjoyment, even though it sometimes has no basis in the present or the past, and often – yes, perhaps most often – has no basis in anything that will ever happen.

40e

Protarchus: Yes, Socrates, that's also the way it must be.

Socrates: Wouldn't the same argument apply to fear and anger, and everything of that sort, that all such responses are sometimes false?

Protarchus: Very much so.

Socrates: What about this? Can we say whether opinions are bad or good unless we refer to their falsehood?

Protarchus: There is no other way.

Socrates: And we realise, I presume, that there is no other way for pleasures to be bad except by being false.

41a

Protarchus: No, Socrates, the precise opposite is the case. Indeed, hardly anyone would suggest that pleasures and pains are bad on account of falsity. No, it is due to the occurrence of a different badness which is extensive and varied.

Socrates: Well, we shall discuss bad pleasures, and those which are as they are through badness, a little later if we both see fit. But we should now discuss, in a different way, the numerous

false pleasures which are so often present and arising within us. For perhaps we may find this useful in making our decision.

41b

Protarchus: Yes. It must be helpful, but only if there are, in fact, pleasures like this.

Socrates: But, Protarchus, in my opinion anyway there are such pleasures. And now that we have raised the issue, this view cannot be left unexamined.

Protarchus: Very well.

Socrates: Then just like athletes, let's take up our positions in relation to this additional argument.

Protarchus: Let's proceed.

41c

Socrates: Well, we said a little earlier, if my memory serves me well, that whenever there are so-called desires in us, the body and the soul are then separated, and divided in relation to their experiences.

Protarchus: I do remember, and that is what was said.

Socrates: Wasn't it soul that desired conditions opposite to the condition of the body, while the body for its part, through its experience, furnished the pain or some pleasure?

Protarchus: Yes, that's how it was described.

Socrates: Now, work out what is happening in these circumstances.

Protarchus: Please tell me.

41d

Socrates: What happens is this. In this situation, pleasure and pain are present at the same time, and although they are opposite to one another, the perception of them occurs simultaneously, as we have shown just now.

Protarchus: Yes, we did.

Socrates: Now, was there something said and agreed upon by us earlier?

Protarchus: What?

Socrates: That both pleasure and pain admit of greater and lesser, and both are in the class of the limitless.

Protarchus: We did say that. What of it?

Socrates: What means are there of judging them correctly?

41e

Protarchus: What sort of judgement? About what?

Socrates: The aim of our judgement about them in such situations is to decide on any occasion if one is greater or lesser than the other, or more numerous or more intense, by comparing pain to pleasure, pain to pain, and pleasure to pleasure.

Protarchus: Yes, this is so. And these are the sorts of things our judgement aims at.

42a

Socrates: What about this? In the case of sight, seeing the sizes of objects from afar and from close up misrepresents the truth, and gives rise to false opinion. However, does the same thing happen in the case of pain and pleasure?

Protarchus: Yes, to an even greater extent, Socrates.

Socrates: Well, this conclusion turns out to be the opposite of the earlier one.

Protarchus: In what way do you mean?

Socrates: In the previous case, the opinions themselves were true or false, and they simultaneously infected the pleasures and pains with their own characteristics.

42b

Protarchus: Very true.

Socrates: But now they change because they are viewed from near or far, as the case may be. And once they are compared with one another, the pleasures appear greater and more intense compared to the pains, and the pains in turn seem smaller in comparison with the pleasures.

Protarchus: This sort of thing must occur under these circumstances.

Socrates: Now, each appears greater or lesser than it actually is, and if you sever this ‘appearing but not being’ from either of them, you will never propose that its appearance is correct, nor would you ever dare to assert that anything associated with this portion of pleasure and pain is ever correct and true.

42c

Protarchus: Not at all.

Socrates: Then, in addition to these, we shall see whether there is a way in which we may find even more false pleasures and pains than these in living creatures, both actually and apparently.

Protarchus: But what are they like? And how shall we find them?

Socrates: It has been said quite often that when the nature of any creature is disrupted by agglomerations, separations, replenishments, depletions, and certain growths and withering, what follows is pain, suffering, distress, and whatever else goes under such names.

42d

Protarchus: Yes, that has often been said.

Socrates: However, once it is restored to its own nature, we agreed among ourselves that this restoration is pleasure.

Protarchus: Correct.

Socrates: But what about the situation in which neither of these processes is happening to our bodies?

Protarchus: But when would that ever happen, Socrates?

42e

Socrates: The question you just asked is not to the point, Protarchus.

Protarchus: Why is that?

Socrates: Because there is nothing to prevent me putting my original question to you once more.

Protarchus: In what way?

Socrates: I shall say, Protarchus, if something like this may not happen, what must the consequences of this be for ourselves?

Protarchus: Are you referring to the consequences of there being no movement of the body by either process?

Socrates: Just so.

Protarchus: Well, one thing is obvious anyway, Socrates. In such a situation, neither pleasure nor any pain would ever arise.

43a

Socrates: Well said. And yet I think you mean that we are always experiencing one or other of these processes, for as the wise say, everything is constantly flowing back and forth.

Protarchus: Yes, that is what they say. And it seems quite important.

Socrates: Well it would be, wouldn't it, since the men themselves are quite important? However, I wish to evade this impending argument, so I intend to get away from it in this way, and you should escape with me.

Protarchus: Tell me how.

43b

Socrates: We should tell them that we accept what they say. However, you should tell me whether all living beings always notice everything that happens to them, so that we are not unaware even that we ourselves are growing, or being affected in that sort of way at all. Is that the case, or is it the very opposite?

Protarchus: Obviously it is the very opposite, for we are hardly aware of that sort of thing at all.

Socrates: Then, what we said just now was not well formulated – that the occurrence of changes ‘back and forth’ brings about pleasure and pain.

Protarchus: Of course not.

43c

Socrates: There is a better formulation, which will be less open to criticism.

Protarchus: How should we put it?

Socrates: That significant changes cause pleasure and pain in us, while, on the other hand, moderate minor changes produce neither of them at all.

Protarchus: That is a more correct formulation than the other one, Socrates.

Socrates: Well, if that is the case, then the life we were discussing earlier is making a reappearance.

Protarchus: What sort of life?

Socrates: The one which we said was devoid of pain and without enjoyment.

Protarchus: Yes, that is very true.

43d

Socrates: So, on this basis, we may propose three lives, one pleasant, another painful, and one which is neither. Or what would you say about them?

Protarchus: I would not say anything different. There are three lives.

Socrates: In that case, not experiencing pain could never be the same as experiencing enjoyment.

Protarchus: No, how could it?

Socrates: So when you hear someone say that to live one's entire life painlessly is the most pleasant thing of all, what do you suppose that he means?

Protarchus: It seems to me that he is saying that pleasure consists in not experiencing pain.

43e

Socrates: Now, select any three entities you wish, say gold and silver and a third which is neither, just to give them more attractive titles.

Protarchus: Done.

Socrates: Well, is there any way that the one which is neither of these could become either gold or silver?

Protarchus: No, how could it?

Socrates: So, based upon a proper account, the middle life may never be correctly regarded as pleasant or painful. And if someone were to think so, it would not be right to think so; and if someone were to say so, it would not be right to say so.

Protarchus: It would not.

44a

Socrates: And yet, my friend, we are aware of people who say this and think this.

Protarchus: Very much so.

Socrates: In that case, do they think they are experiencing pleasure when they experience no pain?

Protarchus: So they say, anyway.

Socrates: Then they believe they are experiencing pleasure at that time, or else they would not have said so I presume.

Protarchus: Quite likely.

Socrates: Well then, they are forming a false opinion about pleasure, if in fact experiencing no pain is, by nature, distinct from experiencing pleasure.

Protarchus: And they certainly are distinct.

44b

Socrates: Now, we should decide for ourselves whether there are three lives, as we said just now, or only two – pain, which is bad for people, and freedom from pain, which in itself is good and should be called pleasure.

Protarchus: But why are we asking ourselves this question now, Socrates? I don't really understand.

Socrates: Then, Protarchus, you do not really understand who Philebus' enemies are.

Protarchus: To which enemies are you referring?

Socrates: Men who give very brilliant accounts of natural phenomena, and who deny that pleasures have any being at all.

Protarchus: In what way?

44c

Socrates: They say that whatever Philebus here and his circle now call pleasures are all escapes from pains.

Protarchus: And do you recommend that we believe them? Or what do you suggest, Socrates?

Socrates: No. But we should make use of them, as if they were prophets prophesying without skill but with a certain harshness of nature which is not devoid of nobility. They have developed a strong hatred of the power of pleasure, and have come to regard it as unsound to such an extent that even its very attractiveness is beguilement, not pleasure. Now, you may make use of these doctrines on these issues once you have also given further consideration to their other harsh judgements. Then, after that, you will hear what pleasures seem to me to be true, so that having considered both arguments, we may come to a decision about the power of pleasure.

44d

Protarchus: That is a good suggestion.

Socrates: Well, let us follow them just as if they were allies, relying on the footprints of their harshness. For I believe they say something like this, beginning with a basic question. If we wished to discern the nature of any form at all, such as the nature of hardness, for instance, would we recognise it better by referring to the very hardest things or those with the most minute degrees of hardness? Now, Protarchus, you must reply to these harsh fellows just as you reply to me.

44e

Protarchus: Yes, certainly. And I say to them that we should refer to the highest standard.

Socrates: Therefore, if we wish to discern the precise nature which belongs to the class of pleasure, we must not refer to minute degrees of pleasure, but to those regarded as most extreme and intense.

45a

Protarchus: Everyone nowadays would agree with you on that point.

Socrates: Now, do we usually say that the commonest and, indeed, greatest pleasures are those associated with the body?

Protarchus: Yes, of course.

Socrates: Now, are the pleasures greater, and do they become greater, in the case of people suffering diseases or in the case of the healthy people? And let's be careful lest we trip ourselves up by answering in haste. Indeed, we might perhaps say that it is in the case of the healthy people.

45b

Protarchus: Quite likely.

Socrates: What about this? Aren't the most overpowering of pleasures those which are preceded by the greatest desires?

Protarchus: Yes, that's true.

Socrates: But don't people with fever, and who have similar diseases, experience thirst and cold and everything else which they normally suffer through the body, to a greater extent? And as they are more acquainted with deprivation, won't they derive greater pleasure from the replenishment? Or shall we deny that this is true?

Protarchus: Well, now that you have said it, it certainly appears to be true.

45c

Socrates: What about this? Are we actually right in saying that someone who wishes to see the pleasures that are greatest must turn his consideration not to health but to disease? And take care not to assume that my intention is to ask you if extremely sick people experience more pleasure than the healthy. No, assume that I am interested in the magnitude of pleasure and the occasions in which the extreme of such magnitude arises. For we are saying that it is necessary to understand its nature and what those people mean when they state that pleasure does

not have any being.

45d

Protarchus: I am following your argument fairly well.

Socrates: And you will actually prove that quite soon, Protarchus, for you are going to answer a question. Can you recognise greater pleasures in a wanton life than in a sound-minded one? Now, I do not mean a greater number of pleasures, but a greater intensity and extent. Think about this, and answer me.

Protarchus: Yes, I understand what you are asking, and I see a significant distinction. The proverbial maxim, “Nothing in excess”, constantly restrains the sound-minded, and they are convinced by it. However, the intense pleasure possesses the uncontrolled and wanton people to the point of insanity, and renders them notorious.

45e

Socrates: Very good. And if this is the case, it is obvious that the greatest pleasures, and indeed the greatest pains, arise from a certain degeneracy of soul and body, but not from their excellence.

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Then we should select some of these pleasures, and consider what precise characteristic they possess which made us say they are the greatest.

46a

Protarchus: We must.

Socrates: Then let us consider the pleasures associated with diseases of a certain sort, and what precise characteristic they possess.

Protarchus: Diseases of what sort?

Socrates: Of an unseemly sort, which the men we called harsh utterly detest.

Protarchus: Such as?

Socrates: Like the relief of an itch and other such ailments by scratching, as they require no other remedy. By the gods, whatever should we call this condition when it arises in us? Is it pleasure or pain?

Protarchus: Well, Socrates, it seems to constitute a mixture, something bad.

46b

Socrates: Now, I was not actually thinking of Philebus when I offered that example. Yet we would not really be able ever to come to a decision on the current issue, Protarchus, without reviewing these pleasures and those that follow them.

Protarchus: In that case, we should proceed to the pleasures which are related to these.

Socrates: You mean the pleasures which involve admixture?

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

46c

Socrates: Well there are mixtures which are physical, residing in the bodies themselves, while others belong to the soul itself, and are in the soul. Then again, we shall find pains of the body and of the soul which are mixed with pleasures, and the combinations are sometimes called pleasures and sometimes pains.

Protarchus: How so?

Socrates: Whenever a condition is being established or is abating, and the person experiences the opposite effects and is warmed as he is cooling down or cooled whilst warming up, I believe he will try to attain the one condition and be free of the

other; while if this so-called bittersweet mixture is persistent, it produces irritation and leads on to a violent state.

46d

Protarchus: Yes, what you say is very true.

Socrates: Don't these mixtures sometimes have a balance of pleasure and pain, and sometimes more of one than the other?

Protarchus: Yes, they must.

Socrates: Now, say that more pain than pleasure arises in the case of a tickle or the itch we just mentioned. When the seething and inflammation is internal, and one does not reach it by scratching and rubbing, only the superficial symptom is dissipated. In such circumstances, the application of fire to the external parts changes the pain to the opposite place by means of the externally applied heat, and sometimes produces enormous pleasure. At other times, however, the opposition of internal to external combines pleasure with pain, either of which may be dominant. The outcome is a violent dispersal of what has been accumulated, and an aggregation of what has been dispersed, yielding pleasure and pain alike.

47a

Protarchus: Very true.

Socrates: When more pleasure is included in such mixtures, the reduced admixture of pain causes tickling and a mild irritation, while a much greater influx of pleasure for its part brings tension, and sometimes makes the heart jump. Producing all sorts of complexions, and a variety of physical distortions and irregularities of breath, it induces complete insanity and mindless ranting.

47b

Protarchus: That's exactly what happens.

Socrates: Yes, my friend, and this condition makes others and the man himself say that he is almost dying of enjoyment of

these pleasures. Indeed, the more intemperate and mindless he becomes, the more comprehensively does he pursue them. And he actually calls these the greatest pleasures, and he accounts the man who lives as much as possible in their enjoyment the happiest of all.

Protarchus: Socrates, you have described adequately the entire predicament of most of humanity.

47c

Socrates: Yes, at least in relation to the pleasures from the common experiences of the body itself when internal and external are combined. However, when the soul's contribution is the opposite of the body's, pain is concurrent with pleasure or pleasure with pain, and the pair constitutes a single combination. We described these situations earlier, that when the body is depleted the soul desires satisfaction, and is pleased by the expectation but pained by being depleted. But, at the time, we did not explain this aspect. But now we are stating that in all these countless diverse experiences, where soul is at odds with body, a single mixture of both pain and pleasure is the result.

47d

Protarchus: I suspect you are absolutely right.

Socrates: But there is one of the mixtures of pleasure and pain still left.

Protarchus: Will you tell me what it is?

Socrates: A combination, which we said the soul often acquires by itself.

Protarchus: Yes, but what do we actually mean by this?

47e

Socrates: Don't you include anger, fear, longing, sadness, love, ambition, envy, and the like, among the pains of the soul itself?

Protarchus: Yes, I do.

Socrates: Won't we find them full of extraordinary pleasures, or need we be reminded about desire and anger?

*Wrath that spurs on the wisest man to rage
Sweeter by far than stream of flowing honey.³*

And of the pleasures which are mixed with the pains, in the case of sadness and longing?

48a

Protarchus: No, this is what happens in these cases.

Socrates: Remember too that the audiences at tragedies are experiencing pleasure and are weeping at the same time.

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: And do you realise that the condition of our souls at a comedy would also involve a mixture of pleasure and pain?

Protarchus: I don't really understand.

48b

Socrates: Indeed, Protarchus, it is not at all easy to recognise this sort of experience in that situation.

Protarchus: It doesn't seem easy for me, anyway.

Socrates: All the more reason to take this example as it is more obscure and will enable us to appreciate this mixing of pleasure and pain more easily in other instances.

Protarchus: Please explain.

Socrates: Would you count envy, which we mentioned just now, as a pain of the soul or not?

Protarchus: I would.

Socrates: And, indeed, an envious person will be manifestly pleased by the misfortunes of his neighbours.

Protarchus: Very much so.

48c

Socrates: Now, ignorance is a misfortune which constitutes what we call a stupid disposition.

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: Well, on this basis, behold what the nature of the comical is.

Protarchus: Please explain.

Socrates: It is, in short, a degeneracy named after a particular disposition. And what's more, this degeneracy, more than any other, has characteristics opposed to what is enjoined by the Delphic inscription.

Protarchus: Do you mean 'Know Thyself', Socrates?

48d

Socrates: I do. And the opposite of this would obviously be not to know yourself at all, as enjoined by the inscription.

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: Now, Protarchus, try to make a threefold division of this.

Protarchus: In what way? I am unable to do this.

Socrates: Are you saying that I have to make this division now?

Protarchus: I am saying so. And what's more, I am asking you to do this.

Socrates: Mustn't anyone who does not know himself experience this condition in one of three ways?

Protarchus: How so?

48e

Socrates: Well, the first is financial, when they think they are wealthier than they actually are.

Protarchus: Yes, there are many people in that sort of situation.

Socrates: But there are even more who believe that they are greater and fairer, and superior in all such physical qualities, than in truth they are.

Protarchus: Very much so.

Socrates: But I think the greatest number by far have made a serious error about the third form, at the level of soul, by thinking themselves superior in excellence when they are not.

Protarchus: Most definitely. ----- 3 Iliad xviii.108-109, Hackforth.

49a

Socrates: And when it comes to excellence, don't most people lay unreserved claim to wisdom, being full of contentiousness and false imagined wisdom?

Protarchus: Certainly.

Socrates: And, indeed, it would be right to refer to every such condition as bad.

Protarchus: Definitely.

Socrates: Then we must make a further twofold division, Protarchus, if we are to appreciate this strange mixture of pleasure and pain which we discern in playful envy. "How do we make the twofold split?" you may ask. All those, who unreasonably hold this false opinion about themselves, really must be categorised just like all other human beings – some are strong and powerful, while others are in the opposite case.

49b

Protarchus: They must.

Socrates: Then divide them like that. And you may, in truth, refer to those among them as comical who are unable to retaliate when they are laughed at, due to their weakness, while you will provide yourself with the most accurate description of those who are able to retaliate, by referring to them as powerful, frightening and hostile. Indeed, in the case of powerful men, ignorance is hostile and base for it is harmful to anyone close at hand, whether in fictional representations or in actuality. However, in the case of the weak, ignorance has been allotted the nature and status of comedy.

49c

Protarchus: What you say is absolutely correct, but the admixture of pleasure and pain in these cases is not yet obvious to me.

Socrates: Well, first take the power of envy.

Protarchus: Please explain.

49d

Socrates: Is it somehow an unjust pain and also a pleasure?

Protarchus: Yes, it must be.

Socrates: Now, delight in the misfortunes of enemies is neither injustice nor envy, is it?

Protarchus: Of course not.

Socrates: But is it just to be pleased, rather than pained, if you ever see the misfortunes of your friends?

Protarchus: No, how could it be?

Socrates: And didn't we say that ignorance is a misfortune for everyone?

Protarchus: Correct.

Socrates: Now, take the imagined wisdom of friends, or their imagined beauty, and any other fancies described just now, saying there were three forms which were comical in the case of the weak, but detestable in the case of the strong. Shouldn't we repeat what we said earlier, that this condition is comical when it is evidenced by one of our friends, and is harmless to others?

49e

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: But do we not agree that this is bad since it is ignorance?

Protarchus: Definitely.

Socrates: But are we pleased or pained whenever we are amused by it?

50a

Protarchus: Obviously we are pleased.

Socrates: And did we not say that envy is what produces this pleasure at the misfortunes of friends?

Protarchus: It must be.

Socrates: So, the argument states that when we are amused at the ridiculousness of friends, by mixing pleasure with envy, we are combining pleasure with pain. For we agreed some time ago that envy was a pain of the soul, but amusement was a pleasure, yet both arise at the same time in such situations as these.

Protarchus: True.

50b

Socrates: Indeed, our current argument indicates that in laments, tragedies and comedies, not only on stage but in the entire tragedy and comedy of life, pains and pleasures are also mixed together on countless occasions.

Protarchus: It is impossible to disagree with that, Socrates, even if someone had a great passion for winning arguments against opponents.

50c

Socrates: Indeed, we proposed anger, longing, sadness, fear, love, ambition and envy, and the like, as cases where we shall encounter these mixtures which we keep referring to now. Is this so?

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, do we appreciate that everything we have just concluded applies to sadness, envy and anger?

Protarchus: Yes, how could we fail to appreciate that?

Socrates: So, are there many cases still left?

Protarchus: Yes, very many.

Socrates: Well, why exactly do you think I showed you this admixture in the case of comedy? Wasn't I trying to persuade you that the mixing is easier to demonstrate in fear and love, and those other instances? I was hoping that once you had accepted this for yourself, you would release me from the obligation to make the discussion even longer by dealing with the other cases. I thought you would simply accept that the experiences of body without soul, soul without body, or their communion with one another are full of pleasure combined with pain. So, tell me now whether you will release me or keep us here till midnight. I think you are going to release me if I say a little more. Indeed, I am prepared to give you an account of all the instances tomorrow, but now I want to turn to the remaining matters involved in deciding the issue raised by Philebus.

50e

Protarchus: Well said, Socrates. Work through the remaining matters in any way you please.

Socrates: It is natural then to move on to the unmixed pleasures in turn after the mixed ones. In fact it is essential, and there is some need to do so.

51a

Protarchus: Excellent.

Socrates: Then, I shall turn to these and try to point them out to us. For some reason I am not entirely persuaded by those who assert that all pleasures are the cessation of pain, but, as I said, they do bear witness to the fact that some pleasures are imagined and not genuine at all. Others give the appearance of being numerous and extensive, but in fact they are compounded with pains and with the cessation of extreme suffering involved in distress of both body and soul.

51b

Protarchus: But Socrates, which pleasures may properly be regarded as true?

Socrates: Those which involve colours which we call beautiful; also shapes, most smells, pleasant sounds, and any pleasures where the deficiency is painless and unnoticed, while the replenishment they provide is perceptible, pleasant and devoid of pain.

Protarchus: Socrates, how do these examples relate to what we are discussing?

51c

Socrates: Well, the point I am making is certainly not immediately obvious, so I should try to clarify it. Indeed, I am not now trying to discuss the beauty of the shapes which most people may understand, belonging either to living beings or drawings of them. No. What I mean, says the argument, is something straight or round, and the flat or solid shapes

produced from these by means of the lathe, ruler and set square, if you understand me. For I mean that these are not beautiful relative to something else, as other objects are. Instead, they are always naturally beautiful by themselves, and they possess certain intrinsic pleasures which bear no comparison with the pleasures of scratching. Now, colours also possess this type of beauty and pleasure. Do you follow? What do you say?

51d

Protarchus: Well, I am trying, Socrates. So you should also try to explain this a bit more clearly.

Socrates: Yes. I mean that sounds which are smooth and clear and send out a single pure note are not beautiful relative to something else, but are beautiful just by themselves, and the pleasures which follow are natural to them.

Protarchus: Yes, this is also the case.

51e

Socrates: But the class of pleasures based upon scents is less divine than that of sounds. Yet, because they do not have pain inevitably mixed in with them, and due to their location and the way that they arise in us, I regard them as a total counterpart to the previous pleasures. Then, if you can follow, these are two forms of the pleasures we are discussing.

Protarchus: I follow.

52a

Socrates: Well then, we should also include the pleasures associated with learning among these if they seem to us not to involve a longing for learning, and no pains owe their origin to such longing.

Protarchus: Well, I agree with that.

Socrates: What about this? If someone who has been filled with knowledge loses it later through forgetfulness, can you envisage

any pain at the loss?

52b

Protarchus: No, not naturally anyway. But in reflecting on what has happened, someone who has been deprived of the knowledge may be pained by its absence.

Socrates: Well, bless you! And yet at the moment we are describing only the natural responses themselves, devoid of any reflection upon them.

Protarchus: Then what you say is true, and, in the case of learning, we experience no pain when forgetfulness sets in.

Socrates: Then, we should state that these pleasures of learning are not mixed with pain, and that they are not in the possession of humanity in general, but of a select few.

Protarchus: Yes, what else could we say?

52c

Socrates: Well, since we have now made a measured distinction between the pure pleasures and those which may properly be described as somewhat impure, we should add the further statement that the intense pleasures are unmeasured, while those which are not intense are by contrast measured. And those which involve intensity and strength, whether such pleasure arises frequently or seldom, we may include in that limitless class, the more and the less, which pervades both body and soul. However, those which do not involve intensity and strength belong to the class of things which are measured.

52d

Protarchus: You are perfectly right, Socrates.

Socrates: Then, there is one further aspect of them we must examine.

Protarchus: What is that?

Socrates: We should state precisely how they relate to truth. How do we rank the pure and simple, the intense and extreme, or the strong and vigorous?

Protarchus: What exactly do you have in mind, Socrates, when you ask that question?

52e

Socrates: Protarchus, I want to omit nothing as I scrutinise both pleasure and knowledge. And if there is a pure form of either of them and an impure form too, I want to make the decision easier, for you and me and everyone here, by making the decision about that pure form.

Protarchus: Very appropriate.

Socrates: Come on then, let us think about these so-called pure classes in this way. We could select one of them first and consider it.

53a

Protarchus: Which should we select?

Socrates: We could look at white as a class first, if you wish.

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Now, can we have purity of whiteness? And what would that purity be? Does it consist in its extreme magnitude and extent, or in the total absence of admixture of any other colours at all?

Protarchus: Obviously it is the total purity.

53b

Socrates: Correct. And, Protarchus, won't we also suggest that this, and not the most extensive and numerous, is the truest, and also of course the most beautiful, of all whites?

Protarchus: Yes, that is perfectly right.

Socrates: So, a little pure white is whiter and also more beautiful and truer than a great deal of mixed white. If we were to say this, would we be entirely correct in saying so?

Protarchus: Yes, perfectly correct.

Socrates: Well now, we do not really need many examples of this kind for our discussion about pleasure. It is sufficient that we realise from this instance that any small, insignificant pleasure which has been purified of pain would be more pleasant, true and beautiful than a great and extensive pleasure.

53c

Protarchus: Very much so. Yes, this example is sufficient.

Socrates: But what about the following point? Haven't we heard that pleasure is always a process of becoming, and that there is no being whatsoever of pleasure? Yes, indeed, some subtle thinkers try to explain this argument to us, and we should be grateful to them.

Protarchus: What do you mean?

53d

Socrates: Protarchus, my friend, I shall explain this particular point to you by asking more questions.

Protarchus: Explain it, then. Ask the questions.

Socrates: Well, there is a duality, and one aspect is just what it is, while the other is always aiming at something else.

Protarchus: How are there two? What do you mean?

Socrates: One is by nature always utterly sacred, while the other is deficient in that respect.

Protarchus: Please explain even more clearly.

Socrates: Presumably we have observed handsome and excellent young men, and also their courageous lovers.

Protarchus: Definitely.

53e

Socrates: Search throughout everything that we say there is for another pair which resembles these two.

Protarchus: I ask you for the third time, Socrates, please explain what you are saying more clearly.

Socrates: It is not anything complicated, Protarchus. No, the argument is teasing us by saying that things that are, in one case, are always for the sake of something else; but in the other case are that on account of which, that which arises for the sake of something else, always arises when it does arise.

Protarchus: I am understanding you gradually, because of the constant repetition.

54a

Socrates: And, my boy, it is quite likely that we shall understand more as the argument unfolds.

Protarchus: Undoubtedly.

Socrates: Now, let us take another pair.

Protarchus: Of what sort?

Socrates: One is the becoming of all things, and the other one is their being.

Protarchus: I agree with you. There are these two, being and becoming.

Socrates: Quite right. Now, which of them occurs for the sake of which? Should we say that becoming is for the sake of being, or being is for the sake of becoming?

Protarchus: Do you want to know if that which is called being is what it is for the sake of becoming?

Socrates: Apparently.

54b

Protarchus: By the gods, this is like asking me, “Protarchus, tell me whether you would say that shipbuilding arises for the sake of ships, rather than ships for the sake of shipbuilding?” and other questions like that.

Socrates: I mean just that, Protarchus.

Protarchus: Then why not answer the question yourself, Socrates?

Socrates: There is no reason why not, except that you should also participate in the discussion.

Protarchus: Very good.

54c

Socrates: Now, I am saying that medicine, and all tools and raw materials, are applied to anything for the sake of becoming, but that each process of becoming, for its part, arises for the sake of some particular being, and that becoming in general arises for the sake of being in general.

Protarchus: Yes, that could not be clearer.

Socrates: Therefore, if in fact pleasure is a process of becoming, it would necessarily arise for the sake of some being.

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: Well, that for the sake of which anything which comes to be, for the sake of something else, always arises, that belongs to the rank of the good. However, my excellent friend, anything which arises for the sake of something else should be assigned a different rank.

Protarchus: Absolutely necessary.

54d

Socrates: Now, if pleasure is in fact a process of becoming, would we be assigning it correctly if we allocated it a rank other

than the rank of the good?

Protarchus: Yes, that would be perfectly correct.

Socrates: Therefore, as I actually said at the beginning of this discussion, we should be grateful to whoever declared that pleasure is a process of becoming which has no being whatsoever. For it is obvious that this person makes a laughing stock of those who assert that pleasure is good.

Protarchus: Definitely.

54e

Socrates: And, indeed, this same person will also make a laughing stock of those whose objective consists in processes of becoming.

Protarchus: In what way? And what sort of people are you referring to?

Socrates: I am referring to all who obtain relief from hunger and thirst, or anything of that sort, which may be relieved by a process of becoming, and are delighted by the process, as it is itself a pleasure. They say that life would be unbearable without the experiences of thirst and hunger, and all the others which may be said to follow upon such conditions.

55a

Protarchus: Well, they seem to believe that anyway.

Socrates: Now, I presume we would all agree that perishing is the opposite of coming into being.

Protarchus: It must be.

Socrates: If someone were to choose a life based upon coming into being and perishing, he would not be choosing that third kind of life, in which there is neither pleasure nor pain, but only the purest possible understanding.

Protarchus: It seems, Socrates, that a lot of unreasonable consequences follow, once anyone proposes to us that pleasure is good.

Socrates: A lot. And there is even more to be said.

Protarchus: In what way?

55b

Socrates: How can it be reasonable that there is nothing good or fair, in body or in anything else, except in soul? And that the good in the soul should be pleasure alone, while courage and self-control and reason, and the other goods which the soul contains, are neither good nor fair? What is more, must we refer to a man who is not experiencing pleasure but is in pain as bad, once he is in pain, even if he is the most excellent of men? And what's more, must we refer to the man who experiences pleasure as distinguished in excellence, to the extent that he experiences more pleasure when he is pleased?

55c

Protarchus: All these conclusions are as unreasonable as can be, Socrates.

Socrates: Then, we should not be trying our utmost to conduct a comprehensive review of pleasure whilst showing scant regard for reason and knowledge. Let us make bold, and test these thoroughly for any unsoundness, so that we may discern what is naturally purest in them, and then make our joint decision by referring to what is truest in these two and in pleasure.

Protarchus: Right.

55d

Socrates: Well then, I believe that the knowledge involved in learning relates either to a skill or to education and nurture. Is this so?

Protarchus: It is so.

Socrates: Now, in the case of manual skills, let us consider firstly whether some of them involve more knowledge, while others involve less, and whether we should regard the former as entirely pure, and the latter as less pure.

Protarchus: Yes, we must do this.

Socrates: Then, should we deal with the chief skills separately in each case?

Protarchus: What are they, and how should we deal with them?

55e

Socrates: For instance, if someone were to remove counting, measuring and weighing from all of the skills, what was left of each would, so to speak, be worthless.

Protarchus: Yes, worthless indeed.

Socrates: Anyway, after that, what is left would be estimation, and the exercise of the senses through experience and habit, and recourse to the powers of guesswork, which many call skills, since this ability is developed through study and hard work.

56a

Protarchus: What you are saying is undeniable.

Socrates: Now, in the first place, music is presumably full of this as it harmonises the sounds, not through measurement but by inference based on experience. Flute-playing, in general, seeks out the measure of each note by inference, and so to a large extent it involves an absence of clarity, combined with little certainty.

Protarchus: Very true.

56b

Socrates: And we shall find that the same applies to medicine, farming, navigation and military strategy.

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: But building, I believe, uses far more measurements and instruments, and these provide it with much precision, and render it the most skilful of the various branches of knowledge.

Protarchus: In what way?

Socrates: On the basis that both shipbuilding and house-building, along with numerous other skills, involve woodworking. For this skill, I believe, uses the ruler, the compass, lathe, chalk-line and an ingenious kind of set square.

56c

Protarchus: Very much so, Socrates. What you are saying is correct.

Socrates: Then, let us divide these so-called skills in two – those corresponding to music, which involve less precision in their activities, and those corresponding to building, which are more precise.

Protarchus: Let's do that.

Socrates: And the most precise of these are the skills which we just said are primary.

Protarchus: You appear to me to be referring to arithmetic, and whatever skills you mentioned along with it a moment ago.

56d

Socrates: Yes, certainly. But, Protarchus, should we also say that these subjects in turn are also twofold? What do you think?

Protarchus: What two aspects are you referring to?

Socrates: Shouldn't we point out first that the arithmetic of the multitude is one thing, while the arithmetic of those who engage in philosophy is something else again?

Protarchus: How could anyone ever propose a distinction between one kind of arithmetic and another?

Socrates: This is no minor distinction, Protarchus. Indeed, there are people who enumerate units which are somehow unequal, such as two armies, or oxen, or two of the smallest or largest possible entities. But there are others who would never go along with this, unless someone was to propose that each of the units does not differ at all from any of the countless other units.

56e

Protarchus: Then you are quite right to say that the difference between people who deal with numbers is not minor, so it makes sense that there are two types.

Socrates: What about calculation and measurement used in building or trading, compared to the geometry and calculation associated with philosophy? Should we say that each subject is one, or should we propose that there are two?

57a

Protarchus: Following what was said before, according to my vote there would be two types of each subject.

Socrates: Correct. But do you appreciate why we have introduced these issues into the discussion?

Protarchus: Possibly, but I would like you to reply to the question which has just been asked.

Socrates: Well, it seems to me anyway that this discussion – no less than when we first commenced it, in looking for a counterpart to pleasures – has gone on from there to investigate whether one kind of knowledge is purer than another kind of knowledge, just as one pleasure was purer than another.

57b

Protarchus: Yes, and it is quite clear that that is the reason why these topics were introduced.

Socrates: What now? Did we not discover previously that there is a skill applicable to various subjects, which may be more definite or less definite in one case than another?

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Yet, in these cases, did we not refer to a particular skill with a single name, giving the impression that it was one thing? Then again, are we now behaving as if this definite and pure skill is itself two things, when we ask whether the skill of the philosophic or the nonphilosophic people is more precise?

57c

Protarchus: Yes, it certainly seems to me that this question does arise.

Socrates: Well, what answer do we give, Protarchus?

Protarchus: Socrates! We have arrived at an amazingly significant distinction in relation to the clarity of various types of knowledge.

Socrates: Doesn't that make it easier for us to reply?

Protarchus: Of course. And we should state that these pure skills are far superior to the others, and any of them which are concerned with the endeavour of genuinely philosophic people are immeasurably superior, in precision and truth, in relation both to measure and to number.

57d

Socrates: Let us accept what you say, and placing our trust in you we can reply boldly to those who are so clever at dragging words about.

Protarchus: What sort of reply should we give?

Socrates: That there are two arithmetical and two metrical skills, and countless other similar skills associated with them, which possess this twofold aspect though they share one

common name.

57e

Protarchus: Let's give this answer, Socrates, along with our best wishes to these men whom you say are clever.

Socrates: Are we saying, then, that these are the most precise forms of knowledge?

Protarchus: Very much so.

Socrates: But, Protarchus, the power of dialectic would disown us should we decide that some other skill is preferable to it.

Protarchus: Should we explain again what dialectic is?

58a

Socrates: Obviously it is the skill which understands every skill we are now discussing, at least.⁴ For I believe that anyone who is endowed with even a little reason regards the understanding of being and reality and that which is always entirely the same by nature as the truest knowledge by far. But what about you? How would you decide the issue, Protarchus?

Protarchus: Well, Socrates, I heard consistently and repeatedly from Gorgias that skill in persuasion is greatly superior to all other skills, for everyone is enslaved by it, not by force, but willingly, so it is by far the best skill of all. And now I do not wish to take up a position opposed either to you or to him.

58b

Socrates: I think you wanted to say “take up arms”, but you dropped that wording out of politeness.

Protarchus: Let it be so then, if you think it so.

Socrates: Well, in that case, am I responsible for your inadequate understanding?

Protarchus: In what way?

58c

Socrates: Protarchus, my friend, I was not yet asking what skill or knowledge exceeds all in magnitude, excellence, and the extent of its benefit to us. No, the skill which pursues what is clear and precise and perfectly true, even if it is minor and of little benefit, is what we are searching for now. But look, you will not become an enemy of Gorgias if you grant that his own skill is supreme in relation to its benefit to humanity, while this process we are discussing is the very truest. It is just like the example of whiteness I gave earlier, where even a little pure colour is superior to a lot of colour which is not pure. And now, after intense thought and proper discussion, we should look neither to the benefits of any branch of knowledge, nor to its reputation, but only to whether there is a certain natural capacity in our souls to love the truth and perform all actions for its sake. We should declare that this power deserves close attention, and we should state whether this is most likely to possess pure reason and understanding, or whether we should look for something else which is better.

58e

Protarchus: Well, I am considering this, and I think it is hard to accept that any other skill or knowledge adheres more closely to truth than this one.

Socrates: Now, are you saying what you have just said because you realise that the various skills, and those who work at them, in the first place make use of opinions and are earnestly investigating matters of opinion? And even if they think they are enquiring into nature, you must understand that they are, in fact, spending their lives investigating this universe, how it has arisen, what happens to it, and how it behaves? Is this what we would say? Or how would we express it?

59a

Protarchus: In this way.

Socrates: So, a person like this is not taking on the task of enquiring into things that always are, but into things that are becoming, will become, and have become.

Protarchus: Very true.

59b

Socrates: Now, would we say, in strictest truth, that anything clear arises from these when they have never ever remained the same, never will, and are not so at present?

Protarchus: No, how could we?

Socrates: Well, how could we ever achieve any certainty at all about matters which have never attained any certainty whatsoever? ----- 4 Following Bury's text here.

Protarchus: I do not think it is possible at all.

Socrates: So, there is no reasoning or any knowledge about them which is perfectly true.

Protarchus: No, that is not likely.

Socrates: Well then, we should bid a final farewell to you and me, Gorgias and Philebus, and instead use the argument to make the following case.

59c

Protarchus: What case?

Socrates: That we shall attain the certain, the pure, the true, and what we call absolute, among what is ever the same, unchanging and unmixed, or among whatever is most akin to these. All else should be declared to be secondary or inferior.

Protarchus: What you say is very true.

Socrates: And wouldn't it be most appropriate to assign the most beautiful names for such entities to whatever is most beautiful?

Protarchus: That sounds reasonable anyway.

59d

Socrates: Are not reason and understanding the names which would be most honoured?

Protarchus: Yes.

Socrates: So, these terms are properly applicable, in their most precise sense, to reflections upon what actually is.

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And these are the very terms I presented for our adjudication earlier.

Protarchus: Of course, Socrates.

Socrates: Very well. Now, if someone were to say that this process of mixing understanding with pleasure turns us into craftsmen, with the materials or constituents for manufacturing something spread before us, he would be making a very good analogy.

59e

Protarchus: Very much so.

Socrates: Then the next thing we should do is set about mixing them.

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: Well, would it be appropriate to set out some principles and reminders for ourselves?

Protarchus: Of what kind?

60a

Socrates: We were also reminded of these before, but I think the proverb puts it nicely, that “a good point may be repeated twice or even thrice in a speech”.

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: Then, by Zeus, let's proceed, for I believe that what was said then amounts to something like this.

Protarchus: Something like what?

Socrates: Philebus says that pleasure is the right objective for every creature, and they should all aim for this, and this in itself constitutes the good for all of them. And these two names, good and pleasant, have been correctly assigned to one entity which possesses a single nature. But Socrates denies that these two are one – they are two, just as the names are, and the good and pleasant have different natures from one another – and that understanding involves a greater portion of good than pleasure does. Is that how things stand, Protarchus? And is that what was said before?

60b

Protarchus: Yes, definitely.

Socrates: Isn't there a further point we agreed about before, and could still agree about now?

Protarchus: What is it?

Socrates: That the nature of the good differs from everything else in a particular way.

60c

Protarchus: Which is?

Socrates: Any creature which possessed it permanently, entirely, and in every way, would not ever stand in need of anything else, and would be completely self-sufficient. Is this so?

Protarchus: It is so, indeed.

Socrates: Didn't we attempt in the discussion to assign a distinct life to each of them, one a life of pleasure unmixed with understanding, and the other in like manner a life of

understanding without the least portion of pleasure?

Protarchus: That was it.

Socrates: Now, did we think at the time that either of these lives was adequate for anyone?

60d

Protarchus: No, how could we?

Socrates: And yet, if we went somewhat astray at the time, anyone may now revise it and state it more correctly. He should assign memory, understanding, knowledge and right opinion to the same class, and consider whether anyone would agree to possess or acquire anything whatsoever in the absence of these. Would he accept the most extensive and intense pleasure without the true opinion that he was enjoying it, without any knowledge at all of the experience he was undergoing, or any memory of the experience, for any period of time? And he should also ask the same question about understanding. Would anyone accept the possession of understanding without any pleasure, even the slightest, rather than having it along with some pleasures? Or would he accept all the pleasure without any understanding, rather than having it in turn along with some understanding?

60e

Protarchus: No one would accept it, Socrates, and there is no need to ask these questions so often.

61a

Socrates: In that case, would the perfect, the supreme good which everyone desires, be either of these two?

Protarchus: How could it be?

Socrates: Then we need to understand the good, either in its clarity or in outline, so that as we said we may decide how to award second place.

Protarchus: Correct.

Socrates: Well, haven't we found a sort of pathway towards the good?

Protarchus: What is it?

61b

Socrates: It is as if you were looking for a particular person and you first found out exactly where he lived. Surely that would be a significant step in the search for the person.

Protarchus: Of course.

Socrates: And, indeed, a certain argument has now advised us, as it did at the start of our discussion, not to seek the good in the unmixed life, but in the mixed life.

Protarchus: Certainly.

Socrates: In that case, is there greater hope that the good will be more evident in a life which has been beautifully mixed, than in a life which has not?

Protarchus: Much greater.

61c

Socrates: Then, let us set about mixing them, and pray to the gods, either Dionysus or Hephaestus, or whichever god has been allotted the honour of conducting the blending.

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And, indeed, we have fountains set before us, just as if we were wine-bearers. The fountain of pleasure may be likened to honey, while the sobering, unintoxicating fountain of understanding is like unsweetened healthy water. And we must endeavour to mix these two as beautifully as we can.

Protarchus: So we must.

61d

Socrates: Now, the first question is, would we best achieve a beautiful mixture by combining all pleasure with all understanding?

Protarchus: Perhaps.

Socrates: But this is not safe. I think I have an idea that would enable us to carry out the mixing with less risk.

Protarchus: Tell me what it is.

Socrates: Did we find, so we thought, that one pleasure was more truly a pleasure than another, and indeed that one skill was also more precise than another skill?

Protarchus: They must be.

Socrates: And knowledge actually excels over knowledge, as in one case it was concerned with whatever comes into being and perishes, and in the other with things that neither come to be nor perish, but are always exactly the same as they are. Reflecting on these, on the basis of truth, we regarded the second as truer than the first.

61e

Protarchus: Yes, and rightly so.

Socrates: Now, if we were to look at the truest portions of these two, and mix them together first, would these mixtures be sufficient to provide us with the most prized life? Or would we still need portions which are not like these?

62a

Protarchus: It seems to me anyway that we should do as you suggest.

Socrates: Let us suppose that there is a man among us with an understanding about what justice is, who can give an account accordant with reason, and who also appreciates everything else there is in the very same way.

Protarchus: Very well, let's do that.

Socrates: Now then, will such a man have sufficient knowledge if he can give an account of the sphere itself and circle itself, which are divine, but is ignorant of this sphere and that circle of the human realm, even when using straight edges and circles in house building and other similar activities?

62b

Protarchus: If knowledge consists of only divine knowledge, Socrates, then we are in a ridiculous predicament.

Socrates: Are you saying that we should put the uncertain and impure skill associated with the false straight edge and circle into the mixture with the others?

Protarchus: Yes, we must, if any of us is even going to find his own way home every day.

62c

Socrates: And what about music? We said a little earlier that it is full of conjecture and imitation, and therefore lacks purity. So, should we add this to the mixture?

Protarchus: It appears to me that we must, if we are to have a life which is any kind of life at all.

Socrates: In that case, do you want me to surrender, like a doorkeeper who is pushed and pressed by a crowd and lets the doors fly open, so that every kind of knowledge floods in, and the pure mixes alike with the deficient?

62d

Protarchus: Socrates, I do not know what harm it would do to admit all the other kinds of knowledge once we had the primary kinds.

Socrates: So, shall I let all of them flood into the receptacle, the valley, which Homer so poetically describes?⁵

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: They have all been admitted. And now we must go once more to the fountain of pleasures. Indeed, we have not carried out our intention of mixing the true portions of the pleasures first. Instead, due to our indiscriminate desire for all knowledge, we have allowed it all in at once even before the pleasures.

62e

Protarchus: Very true.

Socrates: Then it is time for us to decide also whether all these pleasures should be allowed in together, or we should first admit only those which are true.

Protarchus: It makes a significant difference in terms of safety to let the true pleasures in first.

Socrates: Let them in, then! And what is the next question? If there are some necessary pleasures, as in the other case, should we also add these to the mix?

Protarchus: Why not? Surely the necessary ones should be added.

63a

Socrates: And yet we said it was useful, and not harmful, to have knowledge of all skills throughout our lives. Well, if we now say the same thing about pleasures, that it is of benefit to us and not harmful to anyone to enjoy all pleasures throughout life, they should all be included in the mix.

Protarchus: In that case, what should we say about the pleasures themselves? And what should we do?

Socrates: It is not us who should be questioned, Protarchus, but there is a certain question we may put to the pleasures themselves, and to the instances of understanding, in relation to one another.

63b

Protarchus: What sort of question?

Socrates: “My friends, be ye called pleasures or any other name,⁶ would you prefer to live in the presence of all understanding, or in the absence of understanding?” I believe there is a particular response which they must give here.

Protarchus: What sort of response?

63c

Socrates: Exactly what was said before. “It is not really possible or useful for any class to be single, solitary and absolute. Indeed, we believe, comparing one with another, that in the case of all these classes it is best for us to live in the company of knowledge of all the others, and as complete a knowledge as possible of each one of us.”

Protarchus: “Yes, what you have just said is excellent,” will be our reply.

Socrates: And rightly so. Now, we must put our question once more, this time to understanding and reason. “Would you like to include any pleasures in the mixture?” Yes, that is what we would say in questioning reason and understanding. And they would probably reply, “Pleasures of what kind?”

Protarchus: Quite likely.

63d

Socrates: Well anyway, our conversation continues as follows. We shall ask, “In addition to those true pleasures, do you still feel a need for the company of the greatest and most intense pleasures?” And they would probably say, “How could we, Socrates, when they present countless impediments to us, disturbing the souls in which we reside with insane pleasures, and not allowing us to come into being in the first place? Indeed, in most cases, they totally destroy whatever offspring we bring to birth by engendering forgetfulness through inattention. But please regard those true and pure pleasures

you mentioned as our near kindred, along with any others which involve health and sound-mindedness, and indeed any pleasures which attend upon the totality of excellence, and follow that everywhere as if it were a god. These you may add to the mix. “But surely it would be quite irrational for someone, who wishes to see a mixture and blend which is as beautiful and as free from strife as possible, to put the pleasures which involve thoughtlessness and all sorts of depravity into the mix with reason, especially if he is trying to understand from this what precisely is good by nature in man and in the universe, and to divine its precise form.” Well, shall we not say that reason has responded sensibly and in accord with itself when it says all this on behalf of itself, memory, and right opinion?

64a

Protarchus: Entirely so.

Socrates: Yes, but something else is needed, otherwise nothing at all would ever have come into being.

64b

Protarchus: What is it? ----- 5 Iliad iv.452. 6 See 11b.

Socrates: Anything which we do not combine with truth would not ever truly come into being, nor would it ‘be’ once it had come into being.

Protarchus: No, how could it?

Socrates: It simply could not. Now, if anything else is still lacking in this admixture, you and Philebus should say what it is. For it does appear to me that the present account is complete. It is a non-physical order which presides beautifully over an ensouled body.

Protarchus: Well, on that basis, Socrates, you may say that I accept the account.

64c

Socrates: And would we be right in saying that in a sense we are standing before the portals of the good, and the dwelling place of its kindred?

Protarchus: So it seems to me, anyway.

Socrates: What, then, would we say is most valuable in this admixture, and at the same time most responsible for such an arrangement being attractive to everyone? For once we have seen this, we can go on to consider whether it stands in closer natural kinship with pleasure, or with reason, in the overall scheme.

64d

Protarchus: And rightly so, for this is of the utmost significance for the decision before us.

Socrates: And, indeed, it is not difficult to discern the cause whereby any mixture at all becomes either extremely valuable or entirely worthless.

Protarchus: What are you referring to?

Socrates: I believe there is no man who is ignorant of this.

Protarchus: Of what?

Socrates: That any mixture which does not somehow involve some measure – and the nature – of symmetry must destroy its own components and, first and foremost, itself. For something like this is not even a mixture, but is truly a jumble which has been thrown together – in fact, a constant affliction to those who have acquired it.

64e

Protarchus: Very true.

Socrates: And now we see that the power of the good has fled for refuge into the nature of the beautiful. For surely measure and symmetry always turn out to be beauty and excellence.

Protarchus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And, indeed, we said that truth is mixed with them in the blend.

Protarchus: Certainly.

65a

Socrates: Therefore, if we are unable to capture the good in a single form, we may comprehend it with these – beauty, symmetry and truth. Let us declare that the three may properly be regarded as a unity, responsible for the condition of the mixture. And because of this unity, which is good, such a mixture becomes good.

Protarchus: You are perfectly right.

Socrates: Then, at this point, Protarchus, anyone may be a satisfactory judge of whether it is pleasure or understanding that is more closely related to the supreme good, and is more valuable among men and gods.

65b

Protarchus: Yes, that is obvious. But it is best to complete the discussion nevertheless.

Socrates: In that case, we should judge each of the three individually in relation to pleasure and reason. For we need to decide which of the two should be assigned greater kinship with the three.

Protarchus: Are you referring to beauty, truth and measure?

65c

Socrates: Yes. But take truth first, Protarchus, and once you have taken it and considered the three – reason, truth and pleasure – take your time, and answer for yourself whether pleasure or reason is more akin to truth.

Protarchus: What time do I need? Indeed, I believe that they differ enormously. For pleasure is the most deceptive thing of

all. And by report, in the case of amorous pleasures which seem to be the most powerful, even the breaking of oaths is pardoned by the gods, as if the pleasures were just like children who have not attained even the smallest portion of reason. But reason, on the other hand, is either the very same as truth, or resembles it more closely than anything else, and is truer than all else.

65d

Socrates: Now, consider measure next in the same way, and ask whether pleasure has more than understanding, or understanding has more than pleasure.

Protarchus: This question, too, is easy to deal with, for I do not believe that anyone would find anything at all which is more unmeasured than pleasure and excitement. And in contrast, nothing at all could ever be more measured than reason and knowledge.

65e

Socrates: That is very well expressed. Nevertheless, you should still answer the third question. Do we say that reason partakes of beauty to a greater extent than the class of pleasure, so that reason is more beautiful than pleasure? Or is it the other way around?

Protarchus: Now, Socrates, no one either awake or in a dream has ever seen or conceived of understanding and reason as becoming ugly, or being ugly now or in the future in any way whatsoever.

Socrates: Correct.

Protarchus: But somehow when we see anyone enjoying pleasures, particularly if they are quite intense, and we behold the ridiculous or utterly base aspects associated with them, we ourselves are ashamed and remove them from view and hide them as best we can, consigning all such activities to the night because the light of day should not have sight of them.

66a

Socrates: Then you will proclaim to all, Protarchus, by sending forth messages and speaking to those who are present that pleasure is not the first of possessions, nor indeed the second. No, the first somehow involves measure, moderation and appropriateness, and all that must be regarded as similar to these.⁷

Protarchus: That's how it appears from what we are now saying, anyway.

66b

Socrates: And the second is associated with symmetry, beauty, completeness, sufficiency, and whatever, for its part, belongs to that family.

Protarchus: Quite likely.

Socrates: And based upon my prophecy, if you assign third place to reason and understanding you would not have strayed far from the truth.

Protarchus: Perhaps.

Socrates: Should fourth place go to knowledge, skill, and what are called right opinions, which we designated as belonging to the soul itself? Do these come fourth after the other three, since they are more akin to the good than pleasure is?

66c

Protarchus: Perhaps so.

Socrates: Then are the pleasures which we defined as devoid of pain in fifth place? We called these the pure pleasures of the soul itself, associated with knowledge in some cases and with sense perception in others.

Protarchus: Perhaps.

Socrates: “In the sixth generation, bring an end to the well-ordered song”, says Orpheus. Then, it is likely that our

argument is coming to rest in the sixth decision, and there is nothing left for us after this except to provide a sort of summation of what has been said.

66d

Protarchus: Yes, we need to do that.

Socrates: Come on. With an offering to the saviour, let's call the same argument to give evidence for the third time.

Protarchus: What sort of argument? ----- 7 Omitting the last three words of this paragraph as corrupt, following D. Frede.

Socrates: Philebus proposed that, for us, the good is pleasure, complete and entire.

Protarchus: Socrates, apparently when you said “for the third time”, you meant that we must simply take up the argument again from the beginning.

66e

Socrates: Yes, but let us hear what comes next. For once I had appreciated the accounts which have been given just now, and became disgusted by the principle which is stated not only by Philebus but also a countless number of others, I asserted that reason is far superior to pleasure, and also better for the life of humanity.

Protarchus: That is what was said.

Socrates: And yet, suspecting that there were many other candidates, I said that if anything turned out to be better than these two, I would side with reason against pleasure in the struggle for second place, and that pleasure would be deprived even of second place.

67a

Protarchus: Yes, you did say that.

Socrates: And after that, it was shown very adequately that neither of these two is adequate.

Protarchus: Very true.

Socrates: Therefore, on the basis of this argument, pleasure and reason set aside their claim that either of them is the good itself, as they are devoid of self-sufficiency and the capacity for adequacy and completeness.

Protarchus: Absolutely correct.

Socrates: But when a third contestant turned out to be superior to either of these two, reason proved then to be infinitely more akin to and, by nature, closer than pleasure to the character of the victor.

Protarchus: It did, indeed.

Socrates: Therefore, on the basis of the judgment evinced by the current argument, the power of pleasure would get fifth place.

Protarchus: So it seems.

67b

Socrates: But it would never get first place, not even if all the cattle and horses and all of the other wild beasts were to make this assertion through their pursuit of pleasure. Most people believe them, just as soothsayers believe birds and judge pleasures to be the best means to a good life for us, and they regard the animal passions as authoritative witnesses rather than the ardent pronouncements constantly uttered under the inspiration of the Muse, Philosophy.

Protarchus: Socrates, we all agree now that what you have said is perfectly true.

Socrates: Will you also let me go then?

Protarchus: There is a small matter still outstanding, Socrates. Indeed, I am sure you will not give up before we do, so I shall remind you of the remaining issues. -----

NOTES

1. See *Iliad* viii.539 for this epithet for the gods. Socrates' characterisation of the problem in this way underscores its seriousness.
2. Theuth was the Egyptian god of the moon, knowledge, wisdom, writing, hieroglyphics, etc. He was often depicted with the head of an ibis.
3. *Iliad* xviii.108-109, Hackforth.
4. Following Bury's text here.
5. *Iliad* iv.452.
6. See 11b.
7. Omitting the last three words of this paragraph as corrupt, following D. Frede.

Protagoras

ΠΡΟΤΑΓΟΡΑΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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narrator: SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

persons in the dialogue:

COMPANION *unidentified*

HIPPOCRATES *Athenian*

CALLIAS *a student of Protagoras, Hippias, Prodicus*

PROTAGORAS *a renowned sophist from Abdera*

HIPPIAS *a polymath, sophist, diplomat from Elis*

PRODICUS *a teacher of semantics, rhetoric from Ceos*

CRITIAS *a leader of oligarchy of the Thirty, Athenian*

ALCIBIADES *a famous and notorious general and politician*

scene: Socrates' room / courtyard outside / the street / the house of Callias

309a

Companion: Where are you coming from, Socrates? Or is it quite obvious that you have been pursuing the youthful glory of Alcibiades?¹ And yet, when I saw him just the other day, he seemed already like a fine man to me. Yes, a man he is, Socrates, since between ourselves, his beard is starting to grow.

309b

Socrates: What of it? You are an admirer of Homer, aren't you? And he says that a youth is at his most gracious when the beard is starting to grow,² the stage Alcibiades is at now.

Companion: Well, what's going on these days? Is it him you are coming from? How is the young man disposed towards you?

Socrates: Nicely, in my opinion anyway, especially today, for he said a great deal to support and assist me. And yes indeed, I have just been with him. Yet I want to tell you something unusual, for although Alcibiades was present, I paid no attention to him, and indeed on occasion I forgot he was even there.

309c

Companion: What could have happened to the two of you to bring this about? For surely you have not met someone else more beautiful, not in this city anyway?

Socrates: Yes, much more so.

Companion: What are you saying? Is he a citizen or a foreigner?

Socrates: A foreigner.

Companion: Where is he from?

Socrates: Abdera.³

Companion: And did you think this foreigner such a beauty that he appeared more beautiful to you than the son of Clinias?

Socrates: But how, blessed man, could the wisest avoid appearing more beautiful?

Companion: What is this, Socrates? Have you been in the company of some wise man just now?

^{309d}

Socrates: Yes, the wisest of them all nowadays, presumably, provided you think the wisest of them all is Protagoras.⁴

Companion: What are you saying? Is Protagoras in town?

Socrates: Yes, he has been here for two days already.

Companion: So have you just come from being with the man?

^{310a}

Socrates: I have indeed, and I said and heard a great deal.

Companion: Well, why don't you recount the meeting to us, if there is no reason not to do so? Sit down here. This slave will give you his seat.

Socrates: Yes, of course. I would be grateful if you would listen to me.

Companion: And we would also be grateful to you, if you would speak.

Socrates: Then, the gratitude will be mutual. Anyway, listen.

310b

Last night, just before daybreak, Hippocrates, the son of Apollodorus and brother of Phason,⁵ banged on my door very forcibly with his stick, and when someone opened it for him he rushed straight in, shouting in a loud voice, “Socrates, are you awake or asleep?”

I recognised his voice and said, “Hippocrates, this man! I hope you are not bearing some bad news.”

“Not at all,” he said. “The news is good.”

“It would be nice if you would tell me what it is,” I said, “and the reason you have called at this hour.”

He stood beside me and said, “Protagoras has arrived.”

“The day before yesterday,” I said. “Have you just found this out?”

“Yes, by the gods,” he said, “last evening in fact.”

310c

And at the same time he felt around the top of the couch, sat down at my feet and said, “Yes. Last evening I got back very late from Oenoe, for my slave, Satyrus, had run away. And indeed I intended to tell you that I would be going after him, but something else made me forget to do so.

310d

It was when I was back home and we had eaten supper and were about to get some rest that my brother told me that Protagoras had arrived. I was even prepared to come to you right away, but then I thought it was much too late at night. Yet as soon as the sleep had relieved me of the fatigue, I got up immediately and made my way here.”

Being aware of his impetuousness and excitability, I asked, “Well, what has that to do with you? Protagoras has not done you some injustice, has he?”

He laughed and said, “By the gods, he has, Socrates. He is the only wise man, and he will not make me wise.”

“Oh yes, by Zeus,” I said. “If you pay good money to him, and persuade him, he will make you wise too.”

310e

“By Zeus and the gods,” he replied, “would that it all came down to this, since in that case I would begrudge him nothing belonging to myself or even my friends. Yes, this is the very reason I came to you, to get you to discuss this with him on my behalf. For as well as being too young, I have never even seen Protagoras before, or heard him at all either, since I was still a child when he visited the city before. Anyway, Socrates, everyone praises the man and proclaims him the wisest of speakers. So why don’t we make our way to him now so that we may be sure of finding him indoors? I hear that he is staying with Callias,⁶ the son of Hipponicus, so let us go.”

311a

And I said, “Let us not go there yet, my good man, for it is still early. Instead, let us get up and go out into the courtyard here, walk about, and pass the time until it becomes light. Then we may go. In fact, Protagoras spends most of his time indoors, so do not worry, that is quite likely where we shall find him.”

311b

After that we went out into the courtyard and walked about. And to test the resolve of Hippocrates, I probed him by asking questions.

311c

“Tell me, Hippocrates,” I asked. “At the moment you are trying to gain access to Protagoras, and you will pay money to the man as a fee, on your own behalf. What sort of person will you be

visiting, and what sort of person will you become as a result? For instance, if you intended to visit your own namesake, the Asklepiad, Hippocrates of Cos, and pay money to him on your own behalf as a fee, and someone asked you, ‘Tell me, Hippocrates, you are about to pay a fee to this Hippocrates, to someone who is what?’ How would you reply?”

“I would say that I am paying a fee to someone who is a physician,” he replied.

“In order to become what?”

“A physician,” he replied.

“And if you were going to visit Polycleitus of Argos or Pheidias of Athens and pay a fee to these men on your own behalf, and someone asked you, ‘You propose to pay this money to Polycleitus and Pheidias, to people who are what?’, how would you reply?”

“To people who are sculptors, that is what I would say.”

“So that you yourself may become what?”

“A sculptor, of course.”

311d

“So be it,” I said. “But in the present case, where you and I are visiting Protagoras, we shall be prepared to pay money to him on your behalf, provided our own funds are sufficient to persuade him. If not, we shall spend even our friends’ money as well. If someone observing our extreme seriousness on these matters were to ask, ‘Tell me, Socrates and Hippocrates, you intend to pay money to Protagoras, to someone who is what?’, how would we reply to him? What other name do we hear people using in relation to Protagoras, in the same way that ‘sculptor’ is used in relation to Pheidias, and ‘poet’ in relation to Homer? What title of this sort do we hear in relation to Protagoras?”

311e

“Well now, Socrates, what they say anyway is that the man is a sophist,” he replied.

“So we are going to pay money to him as a sophist?”

“Certainly.”

312a

“Now, suppose someone were to ask you this additional question, ‘If you yourself were to go to Protagoras, what would you intend to become?’”

And he replied, blushing, for the day was breaking by now and I could see him clearly. “If this is anything like the previous instances, it is obvious I intend to become a sophist.”

“By the gods,” I said, “wouldn’t you be ashamed to present yourself before the Greeks as a sophist?”

“Yes, by Zeus, Socrates, if I really must say what I am thinking.”

312b

“Well, Hippocrates, perhaps this turns out not to be the kind of instruction you are expecting from Protagoras. Were you expecting the kind of instruction you get from a teacher of writing, or of the harp, or from a trainer? For it was not with a view to becoming a practitioner that you developed proficiency in these subjects, but to acquire an education suited to an independent free man.”

“Very much so,” he replied, “and I think this is more the kind of instruction I expect from Protagoras.”

“Well, do you know what you are about to do now, or has this escaped your notice?” said I.

“In what respect?”

312c

“The fact is you are about to submit your own soul to the care of a man whom you admit to be a sophist. Yet I would be surprised

if you knew what precisely a sophist is. What is more, if you are unaware of this, you do not know to whom you are handing over your soul, whether the arrangement be a good one or bad one.”

“I think that I know well,” he said.

“Then tell me what you think a sophist is.”

“I think,” said he, “just as the name implies, that this is someone knowledgeable in matters of wisdom.”

312d

“Isn’t it also possible”, I asked, “to say this about painters and builders, that these are the ones who are knowledgeable in matters of wisdom? And if someone were to ask us, ‘Of what wise matters are painters knowledgeable?’, I presume we would say that they know about the production of images, and reply similarly about the other examples. But if someone were to ask us, specifically, ‘Of what wise matters is a sophist knowledgeable?’, how would we reply to him? What sort of processes is he master of?”

“What else could we say he is, Socrates, except a master of turning someone into a formidable speaker?”

312e

“We may perhaps be speaking the truth”, I remarked, “without actually saying enough, for our response invites further questioning as to the subject in which the sophist makes someone a formidable speaker. For example, the harp player obviously makes a person formidable in the subject about which he is knowledgeable, about harp-playing. Is this so?”

“Yes.”

“So be it. About what subject does the sophist make someone formidable in speaking?”

“About the subject in which he himself is knowledgeable, of course.”

“Quite likely. What then is the subject about which the sophist is knowledgeable, and makes his pupil knowledgeable?”

“By Zeus,” he exclaimed, “I cannot really tell you!”

313a

I then proceeded to ask, “Do you know the sort of danger to which you are going to expose your soul? If you had occasion to entrust your body to someone, running the risk that it might be improved or made worse, you would think a lot about whether you should entrust it to that person or not. You would call upon the advice of your friends and family, and deliberate for many days.

313b

Yet, when it comes to your soul – which you value more highly than your body, and on which the good or bad unfolding of all your affairs depends, according as it is improved or made worse – when it comes to this, you have consulted neither your father nor your brother nor any of us, your companions, at all, as to whether or not you should entrust your own soul to this foreigner who has just arrived in town. No, you heard about him yesterday, as you say. You arrive here at daybreak, and without initiating any discussion or consultation as to whether you should entrust yourself to him or not, you are ready to spend your own money and your friends’ money, since you have already decided that come what may, you must be an associate of Protagoras, whom on your own admission you have never either known or spoken to before. You call him a sophist.

313c

You obviously do not even know what a sophist is, and yet, you are about to entrust yourself to him.”

He heard this and said, “Quite likely, Socrates, based on what you are saying.”

“Well now, Hippocrates, could the sophist be a sort of merchant or retailer of the provisions by which the soul is nourished? For that is how he appears to me anyway.”

“What is the soul nourished by, Socrates?”

313d

“By what it learns, I presume,” said I. “But the sophist deceives us by praising whatever he sells, just as merchants and retailers do when they deal in nutriment for the body. For these people, although they praise everything they sell, presumably do not know themselves which of the wares they deal in are beneficial or harmful to the body, nor do the people who buy from them, unless they happen to be trainers or physicians.

313e

“The same applies to those who parade their learning around the cities, acting as salesmen and retailers to any eager customer. They too praise everything they sell. Yet in all probability some of these, my good man, are ignorant as to whether the wares they are selling are beneficial or harmful to the soul. And the same applies to the people who buy from them, unless one of them is, perchance, for his part, a skilled physician of the soul.

314a

“Now, if you are knowledgeable as to which of these wares are beneficial or harmful, you may purchase learning, in safety, from Protagoras or anyone else at all. Otherwise beware, blessed man, lest you take chances and imperil your most precious possessions, for there is surely an even greater danger in the purchase of learning than in the purchase of food. Indeed, it is possible for food and drink purchased from a retailer or merchant to be taken away in separate vessels before admitting them into the body by drinking them or eating them. Once you

have got them home, it is possible to take advice by calling upon someone who knows what we should eat and drink and what we should not, and how much and at what time. Consequently there is no great danger involved in their purchase.

314b

“Learning, by contrast, cannot be borne away in a separate vessel. No, once the fee has been proffered, it is necessary to take that learning into the soul itself, and once you have learned something, you must go your way, having been either harmed or benefited. Well, we should consider these issues in the company of our elders, for we are too young to deal with such an extensive topic.

314c

“Now, however, in accordance with our plan, we should go and listen to the man, and once we have heard him we should also consult other people too. In fact, Protagoras is not the only one there. Hippias of Elis⁷ is also there. So too, I believe, is Prodicus of Ceos,⁸ and a host of others, all wise.”

314d

Once we had decided this, we went on our way. But when we got to the porch, we stood there discussing a particular argument that had occurred to us on the road so that it would not be left unfinished and we could bring the issue to a conclusion before going inside. So we stood in the porch and discussed it until we had come to agreement with one another. Well, I think the doorman, a eunuch, overheard us, but due to the profusion of sophists he was probably annoyed with the visitors to the house, since when we knocked on the door, he opened it, saw us and said, “Ah, some more sophists. Himself is busy.” At the same time, he slammed the door shut with both hands as hard as he possibly could. So we knocked again and he responded, with the door still closed, saying, “Gentlemen, did you not hear me saying that he is busy?”

314e

“But, my good man,” I replied, “we are not visiting Callias, nor are we sophists, so do not worry. In fact, we have come because we want to see Protagoras, so please announce us.” So the man eventually opened the door to us with some reluctance.

315a

And when we went in we found Protagoras walking about in the portico. Walking in line with him on one side was Callias, the son of Hipponicus, and his brother Paralus, the son of Pericles, who has the same mother, also Charmides, the son of Glaucon. On the other side was Xanthippus, the other son of Pericles, Phillipides, the son of Philomelus, and Antimoerus from Mende,⁹ the most highly regarded of Protagoras’ pupils, one who is developing his proficiency with a view to becoming a sophist. Those who followed behind these men and listened in on the conversation seemed for the most part to be foreigners whom Protagoras had drawn from the various cities he travelled through, charming them with his voice, just like Orpheus, while they followed along, enchanted by the sound.¹⁰ There were also some of our fellow-countrymen in the chorus. When I beheld this chorus, I was especially delighted at the beautiful care they exercised never to impede Protagoras by getting in front of him. So when he turned about along with his cohort, those eavesdroppers divided in two nicely, and in due order, on either side, turned in a circle and always positioned themselves perfectly behind him once more.

315c

‘The next person I beheld’, in Homer’s phrase,¹¹ was Hippias of Elis, seated upon a raised chair in the opposite portico. Seated about him on benches were Eryximachus, the son of Acumenus, Phaedrus of Myrrhinus, Andron,¹² the son of Androtion, and among the foreigners were fellow citizens of Hippias, and a few others. They appeared to be questioning Hippias on astronomical issues concerning nature and the heavenly bodies, while he, seated on his raised chair, analysed each of their

questions and dealt with them in detail.

315d

And then ‘I beheld Tantalus’,¹³ for as it happens, Prodicus of Ceos is also in town. He was in a small room which Hipponicus had previously used for storage, but Callias had even emptied this out and turned it into a guest chamber because of the huge number of lodgers. Now, Prodicus was still lying down, covered in fleeces and blankets. There seemed to be a lot of them. Sitting beside him on one of the adjacent couches was Pausanias from Cerames, and with Pausanias there was a young man, still a youth, whom I thought noble and good by nature, and certainly very handsome. I think I heard that his name was Agathon, and I would not be surprised if he happens to be the young favourite of Pausanias. This youth was there, as were the two Adimantuses, one the son of Cepis, the other of Leucolophides,¹⁴ and there seemed to be some others there too. From outside I was unable to understand what they were discussing, despite my earnest desire to listen to Prodicus, for he seems to me to be an extremely wise and divine man. But because of his deep voice, there was a booming sound in the room which made everything he said unclear.

316b

We had only just arrived when right behind us came Alcibiades, the beautiful, as you call him, and I agree with you. Critias, the son of Callaeschrus, came in too.¹⁵ Now, once we had entered, we spent some time on a few minor issues, and when these had been dealt with we went up to Protagoras, and I said, “Protagoras, myself and Hippocrates here have come to meet you.”

“Do you wish to converse alone or in the presence of the others?” he asked.

“It makes no difference to us,” I replied. “When you have heard the reason for our visit, you can decide for yourself.”

“Well, then,” he said, “what is the purpose of your visit?”

316c

“Hippocrates here is one of our fellow countrymen. He is the son of Apollodorus, and he belongs to a great, prosperous family, while he himself seems by nature to be a match for any one of his peers. I think he wishes to attain a high reputation in the city, and he believes he will best attain this if he consorts with you. So please consider at this stage whether you think we should discuss these issues privately on our own or in the company of others.”

316d

“Socrates,” he replied, “you are right to be cautious on my behalf. Indeed, a foreigner who arrives in great cities, persuading the best of their young folk to depart from the company of others, of family members or acquaintances, older or younger, in order to consort with himself so that they may be improved by his company, needs to proceed carefully in so doing. For these activities generate no small measure of resentment, hostility and intrigue.

316e

“Now, I say that the skill of sophistry is of ancient date, yet those men of old who turned a hand to it, fearing the offence it might cause, disguised their skill. Some like Homer, Hesiod and Simonides concealed it as poetry; others, the associates of Orpheus and Musaeus, as rites or oracular sayings. And I have on occasion even observed people concealing it as gymnastics – Iccus of Tarentum, for instance, and the present-day sophist, as good as any, Herodicus of Selymbria, formerly of Megara. Your own Agathocles, although he is a great sophist, adopted the disguise of a musician, as did Pythoclides of Ceos and many others. All these men, as I have been saying, made use of these various skills as a screen because they were afraid of the resentment. Now, I do not agree with the approach of all these people, since I believe that they do not achieve their desired

objective. For the men who exercise power in the various cities, the very people they are trying to deceive, are quite aware of this subterfuge, while the masses hardly notice anything but simply repeat the pronouncements of the men in power. Now, trying to get away with something when you are unable to get away with it, and being exposed in the attempt, is sheer folly on the part of the person who tries to do so, and, of necessity, provokes even greater hostility in people, for they believe that such a person, in addition to his other failings, is also a rogue. So I have adopted an approach that is the complete opposite of theirs. I admit to being a sophist and an educator of humanity, and I regard this precaution, whereby I admit it rather than deny it, as better than the other one. And I have devised other safeguards as well as this so that, with God as my witness, nothing terrible has happened to me due to my admission of being a sophist, even though I have by now been many years in the profession. Yes, indeed, I have a long life behind me and I am old enough to be the father of anyone here, so, if you wish to pursue these issues, I would be very pleased to conduct the discussion in front of everyone in the house.”

317d

I suspected that he wished to put on a show before Prodicus and Hippias, and take pride in the fact that we were admirers of his who had come to join him. So I said, “Why don’t we invite Prodicus and Hippias and the people with them to listen in to our discussion?”

“Yes, certainly,” replied Protagoras.

“Well,” said Callias, “would you like us to arrange a meeting place, so that you may sit down and conduct your discussion?”

317e

That seemed the thing to do, and we were all pleased at the prospect of listening to wise men, so we too picked up the benches and couches ourselves and arranged them beside

Hippias, since the benches were to hand already. Meanwhile, Callias and Alcibiades arrived, bringing Prodicus, whom they had roused from the couch, and Prodicus' associates too.

Once we had all sat down together, Protagoras said, "Well, Socrates, now that these people are also present, would you please elaborate upon what you mentioned to me earlier on this young man's behalf?"

318a

So I replied, "Protagoras, I will begin as I did earlier with the reason for my visit. Yes, it so happens that Hippocrates here wants to be an associate of yours, and he says that he would like to find out what benefit will accrue to him if he associates with you. That is as much as we have to say."

So Protagoras responded by saying, "Well, young man, if you associate with me, this is what you will obtain. On the very first day you spend time with me you will go home a better man, and the same thing will happen the following day. And every day thereafter you will continually develop for the better."

318b

And having heard this, I said, "Protagoras, what you claim is nothing surprising. No, it is quite likely, since even you, as old as you are and as wise as you are, would become better if someone were to teach you what you did not already know. But suppose the situation were different.

318c

Suppose Hippocrates here were to change his desire suddenly and develop a desire to associate with that young man who has only recently arrived in town, Zeuxippus of Heraclea. Suppose he met him and heard from Zeuxippus the same words he has just heard from you now, that every day he is with him he will be better and will develop, and if he were to ask him, 'What are you saying I shall be better at, and in what respect shall I develop?', Zeuxippus' reply to him would be, 'At painting.' And

if he had spent time with Orthagoras, the Theban, and heard from him the same responses he has heard from you, and he were to ask that man in what respect he would become better every day by spending time with him, he would reply, 'At flute-playing.'¹⁶ So, please respond to the young man in this way, and to me when I put a question on his behalf. Hippocrates here, on associating with Protagoras will, on the very first day he spends time with him, depart a better man, and every day thereafter he will develop in this manner. But in what direction, Protagoras, and in relation to what?"

318d

When Protagoras had heard this he said, "You are putting your question very well, Socrates, and I enjoy responding to people who put their questions well. You see, if Hippocrates comes to join me, he will not suffer what he would have suffered by spending time with any other sophist.

318e

In fact, the others mistreat the young people. For no sooner do they get away from the various skills than these sophists draw them back in once more, against their will, immersing them in the skills by teaching them calculation, astronomy, geometry and music." And as he said this, he glanced at Hippias. "Yet, once he comes to me, he will learn nothing else except what he came to learn, and the subject matter is sound-judgement in relation to private affairs and in relation to civic affairs, how he may best manage his own household and how his words and deeds may be extremely influential over the business of the city."

319a

"So, am I following what you are saying?" I asked. "You seem to me to be describing political skill, and promising to produce men who are good citizens."

"That, Socrates, is precisely the profession I profess," he said.

“In that case,” I said, “you have acquired a great system, if indeed you have acquired it.

319b

For I should not say anything else to a man like you, except what I am really thinking. Indeed, I do not believe that this can be taught, Protagoras, yet, when you say that it can, I do not know how to doubt you. But it is only right that I explain the reason I believe that it cannot be taught or procured by people from other people. Indeed I agree, as do the other Greeks, that the Athenians are wise.

319c

Now, I observe that whenever we gather together in the Assembly, and the city needs to engage in some activity related to construction works, they send for the builders to advise on what they are going to construct. When the issue is shipbuilding, they send for the shipwrights, and the same goes for all other subjects which they regard as capable of being learned and taught. Yet if anyone else attempts to advise them, someone whom they believe to be no practitioner, even if he is extremely beautiful and wealthy and of noble lineage, they accept him none the more for that. No, they ridicule him and cause a commotion until either he himself gives up on his attempt to speak because he has been shouted down, or the attendants drag him away or carry him out at the behest of the officials. So, on issues where they believe that a skill is involved, this is how they proceed.

319d

“However, once they need to decide on the administration of the city, it is all the same to them if the person who stands up to advise them about these issues is a carpenter, a blacksmith, a cobbler, a merchant, a ship owner, rich or poor, of noble lineage or none. It makes no difference.

No one rebukes these speakers for this, as they did in the previous case, for trying to give advice without having learned about the matter from anyone, or without even having a teacher. For the Athenians obviously do not believe that this subject can be taught.

319e

“What is more, this conclusion applies not only in the communal aspect of the city, but also in private. For the wisest and most excellent of our citizens are unable to pass on this excellence, which they possess, to anyone else. Indeed Pericles, the father of these two young men here, educated them well and truly in the subjects for which he found teachers, yet when it comes to matters on which he himself is wise, he neither instructs them himself nor hands them over to anyone else.

320a

Rather they go about, grazing like sacred cattle, perhaps somehow stumbling upon excellence of their own accord. Or take Clinias if you like, the younger brother of Alcibiades here. The very same man, Pericles, acting as his guardian, was somehow afraid lest he be corrupted by Alcibiades, so he separated the two brothers, and placed Clinias with the family of Ariphron¹⁷ to be educated.

320b

But before six months had elapsed he gave him back, at a loss as to what he should do with him.

320c

And I can recount a whole range of other examples of those who are themselves good but have never yet made someone else good, either a member of their own family or someone from outside it. So, Protagoras, when I look at all this, I come to the view that excellence cannot be taught. Yet when I hear these assertions of yours, I waver, and I think you are talking sense, because I regard you as a highly experienced, very learned person who has made discoveries of his own. Therefore, if you

can prove to us more clearly that excellence is teachable, do not begrudge us a response.

Prove it.”

“Well, Socrates,” he said, “I shan’t begrudge you. But as an older man addressing his juniors, should I make my point by telling you a story or by working through an argument?” Now, most of the gathering replied that he should proceed in whatever manner he wished. “Well,” said he, “I think it would be more pleasing to tell you a story.”

320d

“Now, there was once a time when, although there were gods, there were no mortal creatures of any kind. And when the moment of destiny came for the birth of the mortal creatures, the gods formed them within the earth, from earth and fire which they mixed together, and from whatever mixes with earth and fire. Once they were ready to bring the creatures forth into the light, they directed Prometheus and Epimetheus¹⁸ to equip them and assign powers to each, as appropriate. Epimetheus asked Prometheus if he himself could do the allocating. ‘Once I have done the allocating, you shall do the inspecting,’ he said, and having persuaded his brother of this, he made the allocations. To some he assigned strength without adding speed; others, who were weaker, he equipped with speed. Some of them he armed, and he devised an alternative means of preservation for those who were given an unarmed nature. To those whom he kept small, he allotted winged flight or an underground dwelling place, while those whom he caused to grow large he preserved ^{321a} through their own largeness. He also distributed the other faculties, balancing them equally in this way. As he was making these arrangements, he took care that no kind of creature should become extinct. When he had provided them with sufficient means of avoiding mutual annihilation, he devised a protection against the seasons sent

from Zeus by wrapping them in thick hair and hard skin, adequate defences against the cold, that could also protect them from heat, so that, as they retired to their lair, these same defences would serve for each as their own self-grown bedding.

321b

Some he shod with hooves, others with hard, bloodless skin. Then he devised various kinds of food for the various species, the pasture of the earth for some, fruit from trees, or roots for others, and to some he gave other creatures as food for them to eat. These he graced with very few offspring, but he made the creatures that were eaten by them highly productive as a means of preserving the species. Now, since Epimetheus was not wise, he carelessly lavished all the powers upon the irrational creatures. So he was left with the human race still unprovided for, and he was at a loss as to what he should do. In his perplexity, Prometheus arrived to inspect the distribution, and he saw that although the other creatures were suitably provided for in all respects, the human race was naked, unshod, had no bedding and was unarmed. But by now the day of destiny was at hand, on which human beings too had to come forth from the earth into the light. Prometheus, gripped by perplexity as to what sort of protection he might find for the humans, stole the wisdom that resides in skill from Hephaestus and Athena, along with fire, for it is impossible for anyone to attain the skill or for it to be useful without fire, and so it is that he bestows this gift upon humanity.

321e

“Now, that is how humanity came to possess the wisdom for everyday life, yet they did not possess wisdom in civic affairs, for that belonged to Zeus. There was no time for Prometheus to enter the high pinnacle that is the abode of Zeus, and the guardsmen of Zeus were too fearsome anyway. But he entered unnoticed into the shared workshop of Athena and Hephaestus wherein they practised their skill, stole the skill that works

through fire, the one that belongs to Hephaestus, and the other skill that belongs to Athena, and bestowed them upon humanity. And as a consequence of this, the life of man is well provided for, and yet it is said that because of Epimetheus, Prometheus was prosecuted afterwards for theft.

322b

“Since humanity had shared in a divine portion, firstly, due to their kinship with the god, they were the only living creatures who acknowledged the gods, and they set about constructing altars and statues of gods. Then, by means of this skill, they quickly produced articulate sounds and names, and invented houses, clothing, shoes, bedding, and the production of food from the earth. Once they had been provided for in this way, the humans did not live communally at first, and there were no cities. So they were being ravaged by the wild beasts, because they were weaker than the beasts in every respect. And although their skilled craftsmanship was enough to secure them a source of food, it fell short when it came to warfare against the wild animals, for they did not yet possess skill in civic affairs of which warfare is a part. So they sought to come together and preserve themselves by building cities.

322c

“Now, when they came together, they acted unjustly towards one another as they lacked skill in civic affairs. So they were dispersed once again, and subject to destruction. Then Zeus, fearing that our race might perish completely, sent Hermes, bearing respect and justice to humanity, so that there would be order in the cities and conjoining bonds of friendship. So Hermes asked Zeus in what manner he should bestow justice and respect upon humanity. ‘Should I allocate these in the same way that the skills were allocated? They were distributed so that one person possessing medical skill was enough to treat numerous laymen, and the same applied to the other skilled persons. So should I also distribute justice and respect among

the humans in this way or should I allocate it to them all?' 'To them all,' replied Zeus, 'and let them all have a share in it, for cities will not come into existence if only a few people share in this skill, as happens with other skills. And set down a law from me whereby anyone unable to share in justice and respect is to die as a pestilence of the city.'

322e

"Accordingly, for these reasons, Socrates, everyone, Athenians included, believes that few advisers should be involved whenever the deliberation relates to excellence in building, or some other skilled work. And if anyone outside of that few offers advice, they do not put up with it, as you have said, quite reasonably in my view. Yet when it comes to advice on excellence in civic affairs, where it is necessary to proceed entirely on the basis of justice and sound-mindedness, they quite reasonably accept contributions from all men because it is appropriate for everyone to share in this excellence; otherwise there would be no cities at all. That is the explanation for this, Socrates.

323a

"In case you think you are being deceived, please accept this additional proof that the whole world really does believe that all men have a share of justice, and also civic excellence in general.

323b

In the case of the other excellences, as you say yourself, if someone claims to be a good flute player or to be good at any other skill which he is not good at, they laugh at him or get angry with him, and his relatives come and rebuke him for being insane. Yet, in the case of justice and excellence in civic affairs generally, if a person whom they know to be unjust should himself declare the truth about himself in front of everyone, they regard this as madness in such circumstances, even though in the previous case, flute-playing, they regarded

speaking the truth as sound-mindedness. Indeed, they say that everyone should claim to be just, regardless of whether they are or are not, and anyone who is not pretending to be just is insane, because it is necessary for everyone to share in it in some way or other if they are to live with their fellow men. So they quite reasonably accept all men as advisers on this particular excellence because they believe that everyone has a share in it. That is all I have to say on that issue.

323c

“Next I shall try to show you that they do not think that it is present naturally or of its own accord. Rather, it is capable of being taught, and those who acquire it acquire it through diligence.

323d

For people who believe that any of their fellow men have bad qualities, due to nature or chance, do not get angry with them or instruct them or punish them, so that they will not be as they are.

323e

Rather, they pity them. Who would be so stupid as to try to inflict any of this upon people who are ugly or small or weak? Indeed, they know, I believe, that these advantages and their opposites come to people by nature and by chance. Whereas if anyone does not possess those good qualities – which, in their view, come to people through diligence, practice and instruction – but has the opposite qualities instead, the bad ones, surely these are the people who become the target of anger, punishment and admonishment. Injustice is one of these bad qualities, so is impiety, and, in short, everything that is in opposition to civic excellence. Hence, everyone gets angry with every offender, and they admonish them, obviously because this excellence is capable of being acquired by diligence and study. Indeed, Socrates, if you would like to consider what precisely punishment can do to those who act unjustly, this will

teach you that people believe that excellence can be acquired.

324b

For no one punishes those who act unjustly because they acted unjustly with this alone in mind and only on account of this behaviour unless he is inflicting punishment irrationally, as if he were a wild animal. But someone who undertakes the infliction of punishment on the basis of reason does not seek vengeance for the past injustice, for that would not undo what had been done. Rather, it is inflicted for the sake of the future, so that the wrongdoer himself will not act unjustly again.

324c

Nor will anyone who sees this fellow punished. And someone who thinks like this is of the view that excellence can be instilled by education, since he inflicts punishment as a deterrent. Now, this view is held by all those who inflict punishment in private or in public. People in general, and your fellow Athenians in particular, seek vengeance and punish those who in their view act unjustly.

So, based on this argument, the Athenians are included among those who believe that excellence can be procured and is capable of being taught.

324d

“Well, Socrates, it seems, to me anyway, that you have been given adequate proof that it is reasonable for your fellow citizens to accept the blacksmith and the cobbler as advisers on civic affairs, and that they believe that excellence can be imparted and is capable of being taught.

324e

“Now, there is still one puzzle left, the issue you raised about the good men. Why, exactly, is it that good men instruct their own sons in the broad range of subjects for which teachers can be found, and make them wise therein, yet when it comes to the excellence in which they themselves are good, they make their

sons no better than anyone else? Now, on this issue, Socrates, I shall no longer recount a story to you, but an argument. Well, think about this. Is there or is there not one thing in which all the citizens must share if there is to be a city? Indeed, the resolution of the difficulty you raise lies in this question and nowhere else. For if there is one, and this one is not the skill of the builder, the blacksmith or the potter, but justice, sound-mindedness and holiness, and what I collectively refer to as one thing, the excellence of man, if this is what everyone should share in, and if all men should act in consort with this if they wish to learn or enact anything else, and if anyone, child, man or woman, who has no share in this should be instructed and punished until they have become better because of the punishment, and if anyone who does not heed the punishment and instruction should be cast out of the city or put to death because he is incurable, if this is how matters stand, and yet in spite of its nature good men teach their sons everything else with the exception of this, behold how strangely good men are behaving. For we have shown that they believe that this can be taught privately and publicly. Yet, in spite of the fact that this can be taught and cultivated, do they really teach those other subjects to their sons – the ones that do not carry the death penalty should the boys lack the knowledge thereof – while, on the other hand, failing to teach or lavish the utmost care on that subject which does carry the penalty of death or exile for their sons, if they neither learn this nor cultivate excellence, and not just death, but confiscation of their property, and, in short, the total overthrow of their family? No, Socrates, we must believe that they teach and admonish them all through their lives, beginning when they are small children.

325d

“As soon as someone can understand what is being said, his nurse, mother, trainer and even his father exert themselves so that the child may excel, teaching him with every word and

deed, and pointing out that this is just, that unjust; this is noble, that base; this is sacred, that profane; do this, but do not do that. If he obeys willingly, all is well, but otherwise they correct him with threats and blows as though he were a twisted and bent piece of wood. Afterwards they send him to various teachers, directing them to attend much more to the proper conduct of the children than to writing and lyre-playing. The teachers attend to these matters, and once the children have learned writing and are beginning to understand the written word just as well as the spoken word, they provide them with the works of good poets to read in the classroom, and compel them to learn these by heart. These contain many words of warning and numerous narratives, praises and eulogies of the good men of old, so that the child may be inspired to imitate them, and may yearn to become a man of this sort. The lyre teachers, doing the same sort of thing, pay attention to sound-mindedness and how the young people may refrain from doing wrong. What is more, once they have learned to play the harp, they teach them the works of some other good poets, lyric poets, which they arrange to the tunes of the harp, and they compel the rhythms and harmonies to take up their abode in the souls of children so that they may be gentler, and be effective in word and deed by becoming more graceful and harmonious, for the whole life of man stands in need of grace and harmony.

326c

And, in addition even to this, they send them to trainers so that their bodies may be in better shape to act as the servant of the mind, which is now so effective, and they may not be compelled to turn cowards, either in war or any other situations, due to the poor condition of their bodies. Those who are in the best position to do all this do it best, and it is the wealthy who are best able to do so, and their sons attend teachers, beginning at the earliest possible age, and giving it up at the latest possible age. Once they are quit of their teachers, the city, for its part,

compels them to learn the laws and to live in accord therewith, in accord with that pattern, so that they do not behave in a random manner of their own volition. Rather, they act as writing teachers do with children who are not yet skilled at writing. They write letters in outline with their stylus, and then give the tablet, thus inscribed, to the child, and make him write with the lines as a guide. So too does the city write its laws, which are inventions of good lawgivers of times past. It compels people to rule and be ruled in accordance with these, and punishes anyone who departs from them. And the name of this punishment, both among yourselves here and everywhere else, is correction, for justice provides correction. Now, when so much attention is paid to excellence, privately and publicly, are you really surprised, Socrates, and puzzled as to whether excellence can be taught? But there is no cause for surprise. No, there would be much more cause for surprise if it could not be taught.

327a

“So why do so many sons of good fathers turn out mediocre? You need to understand this too. Indeed, it is nothing surprising if, in fact, I was speaking the truth earlier when I said that when it comes to the matter of excellence, no one should distance himself from this if there is to be a city. Indeed, if what I am saying is actually the case, as it most certainly is, then select any other activity or subject whatsoever and reflect upon it. Suppose it were impossible that there be a city unless we were all flute players, each according to his ability, and everyone taught this to everyone else in public and in private, and rebuked anyone who did not play well, and did not hold back in doing so. It would be just like the present situation, where no one holds back or conceals his expertise on matters of justice and law, as one would in other areas of expertise. For the justice and excellence we exercise towards one another presumably benefits us all, and, as a consequence, everyone is eager to tell

everyone else what is right and just, and give them instruction.

327c

Now, if we were also to have the same total eagerness and lack of restraint in teaching flute-playing to one another, do you think, Socrates,” he said, “that the sons of any of the good flute players would prove to be better flute players than the sons of ordinary players? I think not. No, if anyone had a son with a natural ability in flute-playing, the boy would grow in reputation, and if he had no natural ability he would never be famous. The son of a good flute player may often turn out to be inferior, and the son of an ordinary one to be good. In any case, they would all be competent flute players compared to unlearned folk who know nothing about flute-playing. You should also think about the present case in the same way. Among those educated by laws and by their fellow men, even the person who seems completely unjust is a just man, a practitioner in the matter of justice, if he is judged by the standard of men devoid of education, with no law courts, no laws and no compulsion of any kind to make them pay attention to excellence, wild folk just like those presented at the Lenaean festival by the playwright Pherecrates last year.¹⁹ Certainly, if you fell in with people of that sort, just like those haters of humanity in the chorus of that play, you would be grateful to meet up with Eurybatus and Phrynonidas,²⁰ and you would wail longingly for the wickedness of the people here.

328a

“And now you are putting on airs, Socrates, because everyone is a teacher of excellence, each to the extent of his ability, yet it seems to you that there are none. It is as if you were to ask who the teacher of the Greek language is. There is not one to be found. And in my view, if you were to ask who would teach the sons of our craftsmen the very skill which they have obviously learned from their own father – insofar as the father and his associates who had the same skill were able to do so – if you ask

who in turn would teach these boys, I do not think it an easy matter to produce a teacher, Socrates, even though it is extremely easy to do so for others who are devoid of experience. And the same argument applies to excellence, and to everything else. But if there ^{328b} is anyone who surpasses us, even a little, in our advance towards excellence, we should be grateful.

^{328c}

And I think I am one of those people, and that I, more so than anyone else, can benefit a person in becoming noble and good. And I am well worth the fee I charge, and even more, so much so that the student himself also agrees. Accordingly, I have devised the following system for paying the fee. Once someone has received instruction from me, he hands over the money I charge if he wishes. Otherwise, he goes to a temple, takes an oath as to how much he claims the teaching is worth, and deposits that amount.

^{328d}

“Socrates,” he said, “I have presented you with a story and an argument like this to show that excellence can be taught, and that the Athenians believe this to be the case, and that it is no surprise that ordinary sons are born to good fathers, and good sons to ordinary fathers, since even the sons of Polykleitus, who are the same age as Paralus and Xanthippus here, are nothing in comparison with their father, and the same goes for the sons of other craftsmen. But these two boys do not deserve such denunciation just yet. Indeed, there is still hope for them because they are young.”

^{328e}

Having expounded for so long in this manner, Protagoras brought his speech to a close. I had been beguiled, and for a long time I kept looking at him as though he was still going to say something, so keen was I to hear him. However, once I realised that he really had finished, I somehow gradually gathered

myself together, as it were, glanced towards Hippocrates and said, “Son of Apollodorus, I am grateful to you for encouraging me to come here, for I think it very important that I have heard what I have heard from Protagoras. Indeed, in former times I did not believe that good people become good by the diligence of their fellow men, but now I am convinced, except for one minor difficulty which Protagoras will, of course, explain away quite easily, since he has already explained so much else.

329a

“If someone were to frequent any of our public speakers on these very issues, he would probably hear speeches of this sort, either from Pericles or any of the other accomplished speakers.

329b

But if anyone puts a question to them, they behave like a book. They are not able to answer the question or ask one themselves. Rather, if someone asks even a trivial question about anything they have said, our rhetoricians protract and draw out their oration in answer to the simplest question, like clanging brass that resounds for quite some time, drawing out its note until someone puts a hand on it. Now, Protagoras here is well able to deliver a good long speech. That is obvious now.

Yet he is also competent at answering briefly when he is questioned, and at waiting, and accepting the answer when he asks a question himself, endowments possessed by very few.

329c

“So, Protagoras, I am not quite there yet, but if you were to answer the following question I would understand everything. You say that excellence can be taught, and if I were to be persuaded by anyone else in the world, I would surely be persuaded by you. But please satisfy me on an issue that surprised me when you were speaking, for you said that Zeus sent justice and respect to humankind, and what is more, on many occasions in your exposition, justice, sound-mindedness,

holiness, and all the rest, were referred to by you collectively as one thing, excellence. Please go through these for me precisely, with an argument on whether excellence is one entity, of which justice, sound-mindedness and holiness are parts, or whether all these words I have just uttered are a variety of names for the same one thing. This is my only remaining desire.”

329d

“Well, Socrates,” he replied, “that is an easy question to answer. Excellence is one, and you are asking about parts of it.”

“Are they parts”, I said, “just as the parts of the face are parts – mouth, nose, eyes and ears? Or are they like the parts of gold, which do not differ in any way either from one another or from the whole, except in being large or small?”

329e

“In the former sense, Socrates, in my view, as the parts of the face relate to the face as a whole.”

“Now, do people also share in these, the parts of excellence, some sharing in one part and someone else sharing in another, or is it necessary that someone who has acquired one has them all?”

“Not at all,” he replied. “Many people are courageous yet unjust, or just but not wise.”

330a

“So are these also parts of excellence, wisdom and courage?”

“Of course,” he said, “most emphatically. And wisdom is the most important part.”

“And is each of them different from the other?” I asked.

“Yes.”

330b

“And does each of them possess its own particular capacity? I mean, are they like the parts of the face, where the eye is not

like the ear, nor does it have the same capacity, nor is any part like another part, either in its capacity or on any other basis? Is this also the case with the parts of excellence, that one part is not like the other, neither in itself nor in its capacity? Or is it quite obvious that this is the case, if it really conforms to our example anyway?"

"Yes, this is the case, Socrates," he said.

And I said, "So no other part of excellence is like knowledge, no other part is like justice, or courage or sound-mindedness or holiness."

"No," he replied.

330c

"Come on, then," I said. "Together let us consider what sort of thing each of them is. Let us ask this question first. Is justice a something or not a something? I think it is, but what about you?"

"I think so too," he replied.

"What about this? If someone were to ask you and me, 'Protagoras and Socrates, please tell me about this thing which you have named just now as justice. Is this itself just or unjust?' I would reply that it is just, but how would you cast your vote? The same way as me, or the other way?"

"The same," he replied.

330d

"So, in response to the questioner, I would say that justice is the sort of thing that is just. Would you say so too?"

"Yes," he said.

"If he were to go on and ask us, 'Wouldn't you also say that there is holiness?' I think we would agree."

"Yes," said he.

“Wouldn’t you say that it too is a something? We would agree to this wouldn’t we?”

He also concurred with this.

330e

“Would you say that this thing itself is the sort of thing that is, by nature, holy or unholy? Now, I myself would be annoyed by that question and I would say, ‘Speak respectfully, my man. Scarcely anything else would be holy if holiness itself were not holy.’ What about you? Would you respond in a similar manner?”

“Very much so,” he said.

“After this, if he were also to ask us, ‘Well, what were you saying a little earlier? Perhaps I did not hear you aright. I thought the two of you said that the parts of excellence are so disposed towards one another that one of them is not like the other.’”

331a

“I would reply that for the most part you have heard right, but if you think that I said so too, you have misheard, for Protagoras here gave this answer. I was just asking the questions.

“Now, if he were to say, ‘Is this fellow speaking the truth, Protagoras? Are you the one who says that in the case of excellence one part is not like another? Is this your statement?’ What answer would you give him?”

“I would have to agree, Socrates,” he said.

331b

“Well, Protagoras, having agreed to that, what answer would we give him if he were to ask us further, ‘So, is holiness not like something just, and is justice not like something holy but like something unholy? And is holiness like something that is not just, and is it therefore unjust, and justice unholy?’ What reply shall we give him? Now, I myself would say, on my own behalf, that justice is holy and holiness just. And I would give the same

response on your behalf too, if you would allow me, either that justness is the same as holiness, or that they are very alike, but most of all that justice is like holiness, and holiness is like justice. Well, let us see if you will disallow that response, or if this is how it seems to you too.”

331c

“I do not think it is as simple as all that, Socrates,” he replied. “I do not agree that justice is holy and that holiness is just. No, I think there is some distinction between them. But what difference does that make?” he said. “If you wish, let justice also be holy and holiness just, for our purposes.”

331d

“Not for mine,” I said, “for I do not want this ‘if you wish’ or ‘if you think so’ to come under scrutiny, but me and you. I say ‘me and you’, because I believe that the proposition will best come under scrutiny once the word ‘if’ is left out of it.”

331e

“But of course justice bears some resemblance to holiness,” he said. “And, indeed, anything at all resembles anything else in some way or other. For there is a sense in which white bears a resemblance to black, hard to soft, and so do others that seem completely opposite to one another. And we said at the time that the parts of the face each have their own capacity, and that one is not like the other, yet there is some sense in which they bear a resemblance and one is like the other. So, based on this approach, you could even prove, if you wanted to, that these too are all similar to one another. But it is not right to refer to things that possess some similarity as similar, even when the similarity is very minor, or to refer to things that possess some dissimilarity as dissimilar.”

Now, I was surprised, and said to him, “So is this your view of the relationship between the just and the holy? Is there only a slight similarity between them?”

332a

"No," he said, "this is not exactly the situation. Then again, it is not as you seem to think it is either."

"Very well," said I, "since you are not well disposed towards this we should let it go and investigate something else you said. Is there something you call folly?"

"Yes."

"And the complete opposite of this thing is wisdom, isn't it?"

"So it seems to me anyway," he replied.

"And whenever people behave properly and beneficially, do you think they are sound-minded when behaving in this way, or the opposite?"

"They are sound-minded," he said.

332b

"Isn't it by sound-mindedness that they are sound-minded?"

"Necessarily."

"Those who do not behave properly behave foolishly, and behaving in this way they are not soundminded, are they?"

"I agree," he said.

"So, is behaving foolishly the opposite of behaving sound-mindedly?"

"Yes."

"Now, whatever is done foolishly is done with folly, whatever is done sound-mindedly is done with sound-mindedness."

He agreed.

"Now, if something is done with strength it is done strongly, and if it is done with weakness it is done weakly. Isn't this so?"

He thought so.

332c

“And is something done with haste done hastily, and is something done with slowness done slowly?”

“Yes.”

“And if something is done in the same way, it is done by the same, and if it is done in the opposite way, it is done by the opposite.”

He concurred.

“Come on now,” said I, “is there such a thing as the beautiful?”

He agreed.

“Is there any opposite of this except the ugly?”

“There is not.”

“What about this? Is there such a thing as the good?”

“There is.”

“Is there any opposite of this apart from the bad?”

“There is not.”

“What about this? Is there such a thing as a high-pitched sound?”

“Yes.”

“Is there any opposite of this apart from a low-pitched sound?”

“No.”

“Now,” said I, “to each one of the opposites isn’t there only one opposite and not many?”

He agreed with this.

332d

“Well, let us summarise the issues we have agreed on. Have we agreed that there is only one opposite of anything, and no

more?"

"We agreed on that."

"And that what is performed in the opposite way is performed by opposites?"

"Yes."

"Did we agree that something done foolishly is done in the opposite way to something done soundmindedly?"

"Yes."

^{332e}

"And that something done sound-mindedly is done by sound-mindedness, while something done foolishly is done by folly."

He agreed.

"In that case, since they are done in opposite ways, wouldn't they be done by opposites?"

"Yes."

"And if one is done by sound-mindedness, will the other be done by folly?"

"Yes."

"In opposite ways?"

"Entirely so."

"In that case aren't they done by opposites?"

"Yes."

"So, is folly the opposite of sound-mindedness?"

"It appears so."

"Now, do you recall that we agreed in our previous discussion that folly is the opposite of wisdom?"

“That was agreed.”

333a

“And that there is only one opposite of anything?”

“I agree.”

“Well, Protagoras, which of our arguments are we to drop? Is it the one stating that everything has only one opposite, or the other one that said wisdom is different from sound-mindedness, although both are parts of excellence? And as well as being different, they themselves are dissimilar, just like the parts of the face, and so are the capacities they possess. So which of them should we drop?

For these two arguments are not expressed in a manner that is entirely in tune. Indeed, they are neither in unison nor in harmony with one another. For how could they be in unison, if, in fact, 333b anything has necessarily only one opposite and no more? Yet, on the other hand, it appears that wisdom and sound-mindedness are both opposite to one thing, folly. Is this the case, Protagoras,” I asked, “or is it otherwise?”

333b

He agreed, very reluctantly.

“So, could it be the case that sound-mindedness and wisdom are one? And what is more, we showed a moment ago that justice and holiness are almost the same.

333c

“Come now, Protagoras,” I said, “let us not flag. Let us consider the remaining possibilities thoroughly. Do you think that a person who is acting unjustly is sound-minded because he is acting unjustly?”

“I would be ashamed to agree to that, Socrates,” he said, “even though there are a lot of people who say so.”

“Now, should I direct the argument at them or at you?” I asked.

“Discuss this argument first, the one that a lot of people hold, if you prefer,” he said.

“Well, it makes no difference to me, as long as you are the person who responds, regardless of whether you hold these views or not. Indeed, for the most part, I am scrutinising the argument, yet it will probably turn out that I, the questioner, and my respondent, come under scrutiny too.”

333d

At first Protagoras was coy with us, deeming the argument too troublesome, but eventually he consented to respond. “Come on, then,” said I, “answer me from the beginning. Do you think some people are being sound-minded whilst acting unjustly?”

“Let it be so,” he replied.

“And by being sound-minded you mean thinking well?”

He agreed.

“And thinking well means planning well for whatever injustice they enact?”

“Let it be so,” he replied.

“Does this mean that their unjust actions proceed well or proceed badly?”

“Well.”

“Now, do you say that there are things that are good?”

“I say so.”

333e

“Well, are these good things the ones that are of benefit to people?”

“Yes, indeed, by Zeus,” said he, “and I refer to things as good even when they are not of benefit to mankind.”

At this stage, Protagoras seemed to me to be angry and combative, and set against answering more questions. So, once I had observed the state he was in, I took care to question him gently.

334a

“Protagoras,” I said, “are you referring to things that are of no benefit to any person or to those which are of no benefit whatsoever? And do you call things of that sort good?”

334b

“Not at all,” he replied. “But I do know lots of things that are detrimental to people – foodstuffs, drink, medicines, and myriads more – and lots that are of benefit; others that have no effect upon humans, but do affect horses. Some only affect cattle, others only dogs; some affect none of these animals, but do affect trees; some are good for the roots of the tree but bad for the shoots. So manure, for instance, is good for all plants when it is spread about the roots, but if you decided to throw it onto the saplings and young shoots it would destroy them all. Oil too is extremely bad for all plants and is utterly inimical to the hair of all other creatures except that of humans, yet it is a salve to human hair and to the rest of the body.

334c

But the good is so variegated and multifaceted that, even in our own case, the very same substance is good for the external parts of the human body and very bad for the internal parts. That is why all the physicians prohibit sick people from using oil on whatever they are going to eat, except in minute quantities to quell the nausea that arises from the odours of food and its sauces.”

334d

Now, once he had said all this, the company applauded his well-delivered speech, and I said, “Protagoras, it so happens that I am a forgetful man, and if someone speaks to me at length I forget what topic the argument is dealing with. Now, if I had

been somewhat deaf you would have thought it necessary to speak more loudly to me than to the others, if you really wanted to converse with me. So also in this case, since I am forgetful, curtail your responses to me and make them shorter, if I am to follow you.”

“So, in what sense are you instructing me to answer briefly?” he said. “Should I answer you more briefly than necessary?”

“Not at all,” I replied.

“As much as necessary then?” he asked.

334e

“Yes,” said I.

“Well, should I give you as long an answer as I deem necessary or as you deem necessary?”

335a

“What I have heard, anyway,” said I, “is that you yourself are able and can, if you wish, teach others to speak at such length that the speech never peters out, and, what is more, to speak with such brevity on the very same subject that no one could be more brief than you. Now, if you intend to engage in discourse with me, please employ the latter mode of speaking, the concise one.”

“Socrates,” he replied, “I have by now engaged in verbal contests with very many people, and if I had done as you are instructing me, and engaged in discourse as instructed by my adversary, I would have looked no better than anyone else, nor would the name of Protagoras be known among the Greeks.”

335b

I then recognised that he was not pleased with his own responses, the ones he had given earlier, and that he was not prepared to engage in discourse in the role of respondent, if he had a choice.

335c

So, having decided that it was not my role to be present at his gatherings any longer, I said, “Well, Protagoras, neither am I comfortable about conducting our meeting in a manner contrary to your sentiments, but whenever you are prepared to engage in discourse in a way that I can follow, then I shall discourse with you. For they say that you are wise and can conduct gatherings based upon lengthy speeches or concise speeches, and you confirm this yourself, while for my part I am not able to handle these lengthy speeches, although I wish I could. But since you are able to do both, you should have co-operated with us so that the gathering might have proceeded. And now, since you are unwilling, and I have some business and need to be elsewhere, I am unable to remain with you as you make these lengthy speeches. So I shall depart, although I might well have enjoyed hearing you deliver them.”

335d

Once I had said this, I was getting up to leave, and, as I was doing so, Callias grabs my hand with his right hand, tugs this worn cloak of mine with his left, and says, “We shall not let you go, Socrates, for once you depart our dialogue will not proceed in the same way. So, I am asking you to remain with us, for there is nothing that would please me more than hearing yourself and Protagoras engaging in discourse. Come on, please do us all this favour.”

335e

At that stage I had stood up to make my exit, and I said, “Son of Hipponicus, I always admire your love of wisdom, and now, in particular, I praise it and love it, and so I would like to grant you a favour if you were to ask me to do something I can do. But at the moment it is as if you were asking me to follow Criso, the champion runner from Himera, when he is at his best, or to run and keep pace with one of the long-distance runners or those who can run all day, for I would reply that I want this for myself much more than you do. But I simply cannot keep pace with

these runners. So, if you want to see myself and Criso running in the same race, you must ask him to drop his pace, for I am unable to run quickly, while he is capable of running slowly.

336b

Now, if you are eager to hear Protagoras and myself, please ask him to answer me now in the same way he answered at first, briefly, just responding to what is asked. Otherwise, what dialogue will there be? For I thought, anyway, that meeting and engaging in discourse with one another was different from public speech-making.”

“But you see, Socrates,” he replied, “Protagoras seems justified in claiming that he himself should be allowed to engage in discourse in whatever manner he prefers, and you seem justified in claiming that he should speak in the manner you prefer.”

336c

At this point Alcibiades took issue and said, “That is not right, Callias! Socrates here concedes that he has no capacity for lengthy speeches, and here he gives way to Protagoras. Yet, in his ability to carry on discourse, and knowing how to present an argument and deal with one, I would be surprised if he gave way to any person. Now, if Protagoras also agrees that he is inferior to Socrates in discourse, that is enough for Socrates. But if he is opposed, let him engage in discourse without stretching out each answer into a lengthy speech, beating arguments down, being unwilling to present an argument, and taking so long that most of the listeners forget what the question was about. Yet I assure you that Socrates will not forget, even though he plays games and claims to be forgetful. Now, since each of us should present his own viewpoint, it seems to me that Socrates is speaking more reasonably.”

336e

I think Critias was the one who spoke after Alcibiades. “Prodicus and Hippias,” he said, “I think Callias is much disposed towards Protagoras, while Alcibiades is always eager for victory in whatever he takes on. But we should not take sides in this, either for Socrates or for Protagoras.

337a

No, we should jointly ask both of them not to break up the gathering in mid-course.”

Once he had said this, Prodicus in turn said, “I think you have expressed that nicely, Critias.

337b

Indeed, those who are present at discussions of this sort should grant a common hearing to both parties, but not as equals for they are not the same. We should indeed grant a common hearing to both and not assign equal status to each. Assign greater status to the more wise and less to the more foolish. I, for my part, Protagoras and Socrates, think it best that you agree to debate these issues rather than arguing over them, for friends also debate with friends in a spirit of good will, while disputants and enemies argue with one another. So, the fairest way to conduct your meeting is through debate, for in this way you, the speakers, will best be held in good repute by us listeners, even though you may not be praised. For a good reputation rests in the souls of your listeners with no accompanying deception, while praise expressed in words is often falsely expressed and contrary to the opinion of the speaker. We, your listeners, for our part, would be most gladdened by this approach rather than pleased, for being gladdened is learning something and acquiring understanding just in the mind, while being pleased is eating something or experiencing some other pleasure just in the body.”

337d

When Prodicus had said all this, the vast majority of those present accepted it. The wise Hippias spoke after Prodicus. “Gentlemen here present,” he said, “I consider you all to be kindred, family and fellow citizens, by nature but not by convention, for by nature like is kindred to like, while convention, the tyrant of humanity, exercises force in general opposition to nature. So, it would be disgraceful for us who understand the nature of things, we who are the wisest of the Greeks, gathered together now for this very reason in the very shrine of wisdom of the Greek world and, in this, the greatest and most prosperous household in that very city, it would be a disgrace, I say, if we were to display nothing worthy of our status but were to quarrel with one another just like commonest of people. So, Protagoras and Socrates, I have a request. I advise you to come to an agreement as though you were being brought to a middle ground by us arbitrators. Socrates, you should not pursue this accurate form of discourse that is excessively short if it does not please Protagoras. You should, rather, let go, and loose the restraints upon the speeches so that they may sound more grandiose and elegant to us. Nor should Protagoras, for his part, hoist every sail and run before the wind, hastening out into an ocean of words, out of sight of land. Instead, you should both steer a middle course. So do as I say, and on my advice select an umpire or overseer or president who will keep watch over the due measure of your speeches in each case.”

338c

The company was pleased at this, and everyone signalled their approval. Callias would not allow me to depart, and they asked me to select an overseer. I said that it would be a shame to select an adjudicator for the discussions. “For,” said I, “if the person chosen were of lesser rate than the two of us, it would be inappropriate that an inferior should oversee his superiors. If he were just like us, that would not be right either, for someone

like us would behave as we do and it would be pointless to choose him. And so, you will select someone who is superior to both of us.

338d

But, in truth, I think it is an impossibility for you to select someone who is wiser than this man, Protagoras. And if you choose someone who is not superior, but you assert that he is, this would also debase Protagoras by treating him like an ordinary fellow and assigning him a supervisor. As for myself, well, it makes no difference to me. So, here is what I propose to do so that the meeting and conversation you are all so keen on may take place. If Protagoras does not wish to answer questions, then he should ask questions and I shall answer. At the same time, I shall try to show him how, in my view, a respondent should answer a question. And since I am prepared to answer as many questions as the man wishes to ask, he should in turn submit to me and respond in a similar manner. Now, if he seems reluctant to answer a particular question he is asked, then you and I together must implore him, just as you implored me, not to break up the gathering. And to this end, no single person need act as an overseer; rather you will all share in the process of supervision.” Everyone thought that this was the right way to proceed, and although Protagoras was not very keen, he was compelled nevertheless to agree to ask questions and, once he had asked enough of them, to take his turn at giving brief responses to any questions put to him.

339a

So Protagoras began his questioning in some such manner as this. “I believe, Socrates,” he said, “that a most significant part of a man’s education is proficiency in relation to poetry. This consists of being able to appreciate which of the poets’ writings are well composed and which are not, and knowing how to distinguish between them and give an account of them when questioned. And, indeed, my question will now

relate to the very matter you and I are now discussing – that is, excellence. But the question will be transferred to the realm of poetry, and to this extent alone it will be different. Indeed, Simonides, speaking to Scopas, the son of Creon of Thessaly, says somewhere, ^{339b}

*For a man to become good truly is hard,
foursquare in hand, foot and intellect,
fashioned without a flaw.*

^{339b}

“Do you know this ode, or shall I recite it all to you?”

“It is not necessary,” I replied, “for I know this ode, and as it happens I have studied it closely.”

“It is good that you say so,” said he. “Now, do you think it has been beautifully and properly composed or not?”

“Beautifully and properly composed in every way,” I replied.

“But do you think it is beautifully composed if the poet contradicts himself?”

“No, not beautifully,” I replied.

^{339c}

“Then take a better look at it,” he said.

“But, my good man, I have scrutinised it quite sufficiently!”

“In that case you know that as the ode continues it somehow says,

*Nor do I regard Pittacus²¹ statement as sound,
even though the man was wise,
when he says that 'tis hard to be noble.*

“You do realise that the same person who said this also made the previous statement?”

“I know,” I said.

“Well,” he asked, “do you think these words are in agreement with the others?”

“So it seems to me anyway,” I replied, but at the same time I was afraid that he might have a point. “Why?” I asked. “Do they not seem so to you?”

339d

“Well, how could someone who makes these two statements show a semblance of agreement with himself? He himself first proposed that it is difficult for a man to become truly good, and a little later in the poem he forgets this and censures Pittacus who says the same thing as himself – that it is difficult to be noble – and refuses to accept from Pittacus the same point he himself is making. What is more, whenever he censures someone who says the same things as himself, it is obvious that he is censuring himself, and so either his earlier statement or his last statement is incorrectly formulated.”

339e

Now, once he had said all this, it drew a clamour of approval from most of the audience. At first it was as if I had been punched by a good boxer. I went blank and became dizzy due to the words he had spoken and the general commotion. Then – and to tell you the truth, it was to give me time to consider what the poet might be saying – I turned to Prodicus, addressed him and said, “Prodicus, Simonides was of course a fellow citizen of yours, so it is only right that you come to the man’s aid. So I think I will call upon you, just as Scamander, according to Homer, called upon Simois when he was besieged by Achilles, by saying, ^{340b}

*Dear brother, let us both, together, restrain
the strength of this man.*²²

“So too do I call upon you, lest Protagoras wreak destruction upon Simonides. And at this stage we really need this art of yours to make a correction on Simonides’ behalf, this art whereby you distinguish wishing from desiring, and show that they are not the same, and make lots more beautiful distinctions as you did a moment ago. Let us find out if this seems to you as it does to me, for it is not obvious that Simonides is contradicting himself. But you should state your opinion first, Prodicus. Do you think that ‘to become’ is the same as ‘to be’, or are they different?”

340b

“They are different, by Zeus,” replied Prodicus.

340c

“In those first lines,” said I, “didn’t Simonides express his own opinion that it would be difficult for a man, in truth, to become good?”

“That is true,” said Prodicus.

340d

“Yes. And he then censured Pittacus”, I said, “for saying something different, and not, as Protagoras alleges, for saying the same thing as he himself says. For Pittacus did not, like Simonides, say that it is difficult to become noble, but that it is difficult to be noble. But to be and to become are not the same, Protagoras, as Prodicus here affirmed. And if to be is not the same as to become, then Simonides is not contradicting himself. Yet Prodicus here, and many others, would probably say with Hesiod that it is hard to become good because

*The gods have decreed that sweat
Is a precondition for excellence.*

*But once someone has attained its pinnacle
It is easy thereafter to keep it
Even though it was difficult to acquire.”²³*

Now, when Prodicus heard this he complimented me, but Protagoras said, “Your correction, Socrates, contains a greater error than what you are correcting!”

340e

“Well, Protagoras,” said I, “it seems that I have caused harm, and I am a comical physician who makes the disease worse in the process of curing it.”

“Yes, so you are,” he said.

“How so?” I asked.

“It would be gross ignorance on the part of the poet to claim that the retention of excellence is a trivial matter when in the opinion of everyone else it is the most difficult thing of all.”

“By Zeus,” said I, “it is timely then that this man Prodicus is present for our discussions.

341a

For I am telling you, Protagoras, this wisdom of Prodicus may well be divine and ancient, going back to Simonides, or to times even more ancient. And you, who are experienced in so many other areas, appear to have no experience of this wisdom, unlike myself who am experienced due to being a pupil of this very man, Prodicus. Right now I do not think you understand that Simonides does not interpret this word ‘difficult’ in the

same way you interpret it. Rather it is like the word ‘terrible’. The same Prodicus corrects me every time, whenever I praise you or anyone else by saying that Protagoras is a terribly wise man, and he asks me if I am not ashamed of myself for referring to what is good as terrible, for he says that whatever is terrible is bad.

341c

So, for example, no one refers to terrible wealth or to terrible peace or to terrible health, but they do refer to terrible disease or terrible war or terrible poverty, because whatever is terrible is bad. Now, perhaps the people of Ceos, including Simonides, also interpret this word ‘difficult’ in turn as bad, or as something else that you do not understand. So let us ask Prodicus, for it is only right to ask him about Simonides’ dialect. Prodicus, what did Simonides mean by the word ‘difficult’?”

“Bad,” he replied.

“So, Prodicus,” said I, “that is why he censures Pittacus for saying that it is difficult to be noble. It is as if he were to hear him saying that it is bad to be noble.”

“Well, Socrates,” he replied, “what else do you think Simonides means if he doesn’t mean this? He is censuring Pittacus because he did not know how to distinguish words correctly. He was, after all, from Lesbos, and brought up to speak a foreign dialect.”

341d

“So, Protagoras,” said I, “you have heard Prodicus himself. Have you anything to say about this?”

And Protagoras responded, “This is very far from being the case, Prodicus. No, I know full well that Simonides meant what everyone else means when he said ‘difficult’ – not ‘bad’, but whatever is not easy, and is brought about through a great deal of trouble.”

341e

“Yes, Protagoras,” I said, “I too believe that this is what Simonides means, and that Prodicus here knows this and is playing a game. And he seems to be testing your ability to come to the aid of your own argument. For there is strong evidence that Simonides does not mean that what is difficult is bad, in the very next sentence, when he says

The distinction would belong to God alone.

342a

“Presumably he cannot mean that it is bad to be noble, when he goes on to say that this belongs to God alone, and he attributes this distinction to God alone. For then Prodicus would surely say that Simonides is a degenerate, and not at all a citizen of Ceos. But I would like to tell you what, in my view, Simonides has in mind in this ode, if you would like to test where I stand ‘in relation to poetry’, to use your phrase. Or if you prefer, I shall listen to you.”

When Protagoras heard my suggestion, he said, “As you wish, Socrates.”

342b

And Prodicus and Hippias urged me on, forcibly, and so did the others. “In that case,” said I, “I shall attempt to recount my own views on this ode to you. Indeed, love of wisdom is most ancient and most prevalent among the Greeks of Crete and Sparta, and these regions contain the greatest number of sophists. Yet, just like the sophists Protagoras was talking about, they utterly deny this and put on a show of ignorance so that people may not discover that it is in wisdom that the ^{342c} Spartans are pre-eminent among the Greeks. Instead, they give the impression that they are preeminent in warfare and courage, believing that if everyone were to realise the means by which they are pre-eminent, they would all practise this wisdom. They

have concealed this fact so well that they have deceived the people in our cities who favour Spartan ways, who then develop cauliflower ears in order to imitate them, bind their knuckles, become keen on gymnastics, and take to wearing short cloaks as if it is through these fashions that the Spartans hold sway over the Greek world. But when the Spartans wish to consult with their own sophists in an unrestrained manner, and are fed up with meeting in secret, they carry out an expulsion of these 'imitators of Sparta' and any other foreigners who are residing there, and consult with their sophists unknown to the foreigners. Nor do they allow any of their young folk to visit other cities, nor do the Cretans, so that their young will not unlearn what they are taught. And in these cities, not only are there men who are proud of their education, but there are women too.

342e

"You may appreciate that I am speaking the truth when I say that the Spartans receive the best education in love of wisdom and discourse as follows. If you are prepared to converse with even the most ordinary man from Sparta, you will find that for most of the discourse he appears quite ordinary; but then, regardless of how the conversation is proceeding, he suddenly throws in a telling phrase, short and terse, like a skilled spear thrower, so that his interlocutor looks no better than a child. Now, there are people today, and among our ancestors, who have recognised the fact that being a Spartan consists much more in being a lover of wisdom than in being keen on gymnastics, and who know that the ability to utter phrases of this kind belongs to a perfectly educated person. Thales of Miletus was one such person, as was Pittacus of Mytilene, Bias of Priene, our own Solon, Cleobolus of Lindos, Myson of Chen, and the seventh was said to be a Spartan, Chilon.²⁴ These were all zealous admirers, devotees and pupils of Spartan education, and you may discern that their own wisdom is of this sort from the

short phrases that each of them has spoken, phrases well worth remembering. When these seven gathered together, they dedicated the first fruits of wisdom to Apollo at the temple that is in Delphi, writing those words that everyone repeats: 'Know Thyself' and 'Nothing in Excess'.

343c

"So why do I mention this? Because this was the manner of philosophy among the ancients, a laconic brevity. What is more, this phrase from Pittacus circulated in private and was praised by the wise: 'It is hard to be good'. Now, since Simonides was eager to gain a reputation for wisdom, he realised that if he were to overthrow this maxim, as if it were a famous athlete, and if he were to prevail over it, he himself would become famous among the people of that age. And so, for these reasons, he targeted this maxim, and it appears to me that he composed the entire ode with the intention of putting it down.

343d

"So, let us all consider this together. Is what I am saying actually true? The first line of the ode would indeed sound insane if, while intending to state that it is difficult for a man to become good, he then inserted a contrasting phrase. For this does not appear to be a reasonable insertion, unless one assumes that Simonides is arguing against the maxim of Pittacus. Pittacus says that it is hard to be good, but Simonides disputes this and says, 'No, rather it is hard for a man to become good, Pittacus. That is what is truly hard.' He does not say 'truly good'. That is not where he applies the word 'truly', as if he were saying that some men are truly good, while others are good yet not truly so, for that would sound silly and unworthy of Simonides. So, we need to suppose that the position of the word 'truly' is changed poetically in the ode, and in some way or other this is hinting at the phrase from Pittacus, as if we are to presume that Pittacus himself is speaking and Simonides is replying. Pittacus is saying, 'People, it is difficult to be good', while Simonides replies,

‘Pittacus, you are not speaking the truth, for what is truly difficult for a man is not to be good, but to become so, foursquare in hand, foot and intellect, fashioned without a flaw’. In this way the insertion appears reasonable, and ‘truly’ lies where it should, at the end. And everything that follows supports the assertion that this is what it means. Indeed, there is a lot more in the various phrases of the ode to demonstrate that it has been well composed, for it is a delightful and intricate piece of work, but it would take too long to go through it in this way. Yet we should scrutinise the character of the work as a whole, and its intention, which is undoubtedly, throughout the entire ode, the refutation of that maxim of Pittacus.

344c

“In fact, a little after this he goes on to say, as if he were lapsing into prose, ‘To become a good man is truly difficult, although it is, of course, possible for a period of time. Yet to remain in this condition once it has been attained, and actually be a good man, is as you say, Pittacus, impossible and inhuman. This distinction belongs instead to God alone.’

*But a man cannot avoid being bad
when irresistible misfortune overthrows him.*

“Now, in the case of the command of a ship, whom does irresistible misfortune overthrow?

344d

Obviously not the unskilled person, for the unskilled person has been overthrown already. So, just as one cannot cast down someone who is already prostrate, but one may cast down a man who is standing and render him prostrate, although you cannot do this to the prostrate man, in like

manner, someone capable of resisting may be overthrown by an irresistible misfortune, but not someone who is not capable. So the ship's captain may be rendered incapable of resistance when a huge storm befalls him; harsh weather may render a farmer incapable of resistance, and the same thing may happen to a physician. So it is possible for the good to become bad. And another poet bears witness to this when he says,

*What is more a good man is
Occasionally bad, occasionally noble.*

344e

“But it is not possible for the bad to become bad, rather they must always be bad. So the capable, wise and good man cannot avoid being bad once irresistible fortune overthrows him. Yet you say, Pittacus, that it is hard to be good. But in point of fact although it is hard to become good, it is not impossible. But it is impossible to be good.

*Any man who fares well is indeed good
While he who fares badly, is bad.*

345a

“Now, when it comes to writing, what is ‘good-faring’, and what faring makes a man good at writing? Surely it is learning the subject. And what ‘faring-well’ produces a good physician? Surely it is learning how to care for the sick. And faring badly in this produces a bad physician. Now, who may become a bad physician? Surely someone who happens firstly to be a physician, and then a good physician, for he may also become bad, while we who are unskilled in medicine may never, by

faring badly, become either physicians or builders or anything else of this sort. And whoever is unable to become a physician by faring badly obviously cannot become a bad physician either.

345c

Accordingly, the good man may also, at some stage, become bad, either through age or hardship or disease, or by some other calamity which deprives him of knowledge. The bad man, on the other hand, may never become bad for he is always bad, and if he is going to become bad he must first become good. So this part of the poem is making the point that it is not possible to be a good man, continually good that is, but it is possible for him to become good, and for the same man to become bad. And those whom the gods love are indeed best for the longest time.

“All this is directed against Pittacus, and this becomes even more obvious as the ode proceeds, for he says,

*I shall not ever cast away my portion of eternity,
In search of that which cannot be,
On an empty, unavailing hope
Of finding an utterly blameless person,
Amongst us, as we feed upon the fruit
Of this broad earth.*

If I find one I will tell you.

345d

“And his onslaught on the maxim of Pittacus is so intense throughout the ode as a whole that he says,

*I willingly praise and love all those
Who perform no base action,*

Yet even the gods do not fight against necessity.

345e

“This verse too is directed against the same maxim. For Simonides was not so ill-educated as to claim that Pittacus praised those who enact nothing bad willingly, as though there are some people who do perform bad actions willingly. For I could scarce imagine any wise man believing that any people make mistakes willingly, or willingly enact anything shameful or bad. Rather, they know very well that all who perform shameful or bad actions do so unwillingly. And indeed Simonides does not say that he praises those who do not perform bad actions willingly. No, he applies the word ‘willingly’ to himself. For he was of the view that the noble and good man often forces himself to praise someone and befriend someone, as often happens when a man has a problematic mother or father or native land, or something else of that sort. Now, when something of this sort happens to degenerate people, it is as if they are pleased to see the degeneracy of their parents or their native land, and to point this out disapprovingly, and criticise it, so that people may not accuse them of neglecting these issues or blame them for such neglect. So they express even stronger disapproval, and add unnecessary feuds to those that are inevitable. The good people, on the other hand, conceal the issue and force themselves to express praise, and should they be angered at being treated unjustly by their parents or their native land, they placate themselves, reconcile themselves to the injustice, and make themselves love and praise their own people. I often wonder if Simonides believed that he himself was praising and extolling a tyrant or someone else of that sort, and doing so unwillingly and under compulsion. And so, what he says to Pittacus is, ‘Pittacus, I am not criticising you

because I love criticising people, since ^{346c}

A man who is not bad, he suffices for me.

^{346c}

*One who knows justice, the profit of a city
A sound man, him I shall not blame.*

‘Indeed, I am no lover of blame, For the tribe of fools is without limit.

‘So, if anyone delights in apportioning blame, he may have his fill through blaming the fools.

^{346d}

Yes, all is fair that is not mixed with baseness.

’ “But he is not saying this as if he were to say that all is white that is not mixed with black. That would be absurd in many ways. No, he is saying that he accepts the average people, and so he does not criticise them. And he says, ‘I am not searching for an utterly blameless person among those who feed upon the fruit of this broad earth, but if I find one I will tell you. This is in case I shall have no one to praise. No, it is enough for me if he is moderate and does nothing bad, since I love and praise all these willingly.’ And he uses the dialect of Mytilene here, because it is to Pittacus he is saying, ‘I love and praise all these willingly’, and we should break the phrase at ‘willingly’ and then go on to say, ‘who perform no base action,

but there are some whom I praise and love unwillingly.’ In your case, Pittacus, if you were saying anything even moderately reasonable and true, I would never have censured you. But now, since you are uttering falsehoods on matters of the utmost importance, while seeming to speak the truth, I rebuke you for so doing.’ So, Prodicus and Protagoras,” said I, “that in my view is what Simonides had in mind in composing this ode.”

347b

Then Hippias said, “I think you have indeed explained the ode quite nicely, Socrates. Yes, I too have a nice account of it, which I can present to you all if you wish.”

“Yes, Hippias,” said Alcibiades, “some other time though. At the moment it is only right, based on the agreement between Protagoras and Socrates, that if Protagoras still wants to ask questions, Socrates should answer them, and if he wants to be questioned by Socrates, then Socrates should ask questions.”

347c

“And,” I said, “I leave it to Protagoras to choose whatever option pleases him. Yet if he does not mind, let us bid farewell to discussion of odes and poems. But I would be glad to bring the first question I asked you, Protagoras, to a conclusion by investigating it along with you. In fact, discussing poetry is, in my opinion, much like what happens at the drinking parties of ordinary, common folk. Yes, indeed, these people, due to their lack of education, are unable to keep company with one another over a drink through their own sound and their own words. So they give respectability to flute girls by paying a lot of money for the alien sound of flutes, and they keep company with one another through the sound of those instruments. But when it is a drinking party of the noble and good, and they are educated people, you would see neither flute girls nor dancing girls nor harp girls. Rather, they are sufficient company for themselves,

through their own sound, as they speak and listen to themselves in turn in an orderly manner, without these trivial playthings, even if they drink a vast amount of wine. And so gatherings of this kind, when constituted of men such as most of us claim to be, have no need of alien sounds, or of poets who cannot be questioned about the topic they are speaking of. And when the majority of people quote them in discussions, some say the poet means one thing while others say he means something else, and they end up discussing matters they are unable to resolve. But the others bid farewell to such gatherings as these, and commune among themselves, testing one another on their own arguments and being tested in turn. I think you and I should rather imitate people of this sort, and setting the poets aside, direct our discussion towards one another on our own terms, putting the truth and ourselves to the test.

348b

“Now, if you still want to ask questions, I am ready to act as your respondent. Or, if you would prefer to conclude the topic whose development we interrupted in midstream, then you should respond to me.” As I was making this point and others like it, Protagoras did not clarify which alternative he would take. So Alcibiades looked at Callias and said, “Callias, do you think, even now, that Protagoras is acting appropriately by being unwilling to clarify whether he will act as respondent or not? I certainly do not think so. For he should either engage in discourse or declare that he does not wish to do so, so that we may all know where we stand here and Socrates may engage in discourse with someone else, or anyone may converse with anyone they want to.”

348c

I thought Protagoras was shamed by the words of Alcibiades. And at the request of Callias, and almost everyone else who was present, he was persuaded very reluctantly to engage in discourse, and he directed me to ask questions so that he could

respond.

So I said, “Protagoras, do not presume that I am conversing with you from any other motive than to investigate those issues that constantly perplex me. For I believe that a line from Homer says it all: ^{348d}

*When two go together, one observes before the other.*²⁵

“For in this way we shall all be more resourceful people in every action, word and thought. But if someone has an insight on his own, he immediately goes about searching until he meets someone to whom he can present it, and with whom he can confirm it. So for this very reason I would gladly converse with you, more so than anyone else, because I believe that you will best enquire into the ^{348e} wide range of issues that a reasonable person is likely to consider, and especially into excellence.

^{349a}

Indeed, who else could I choose but you? You not only believe yourself to be noble and good, just like others who are reasonable but unable to make other people reasonable, but you, by contrast, are good, and are also able to make others good. What is more, you have such belief in yourself that while others conceal this skill, you have proclaimed yourself openly throughout the entire Greek world, giving yourself the title of a sophist, a self-declared teacher of culture and excellence, the first person who thought it right to demand payment for this. So, what could I do but call you into this enquiry, question you and consult with you? There is no other option. And now I want to go back to the beginning, to the issues I was asking you about at the outset, and have you remind me of some, and conduct a joint and thorough investigation of others. The question I believe was as follows. Are wisdom, sound-mindedness,

courage, justice and holiness five names for a single thing, or, underlying each of these names, is there a distinct essence, each with its own capacity, each being unlike the other? Now, you said that they are not names of a single thing, but that each of these five names applies to a distinct thing, and these are all parts of excellence, not in the way that the parts of gold are similar to one another, and to the whole of which they are parts, but in the way that the parts of the face, each possessing a distinct capacity, are dissimilar to the whole of which they are parts, and to one another. Now, if you still think what you thought earlier, say so. If you somehow think otherwise, state this clearly, as I, for my part, will not hold you to that should you now say something different. Indeed, I would not be surprised if you were testing me out earlier when you said what you said.”

349d

“Well, Socrates,” said he, “I am telling you that although all these are parts of excellence, and four of them are fairly similar to one another, courage for its part is entirely different from all the others. You may recognise the truth of what I am saying as follows, for you will find many people who are extremely unjust, unholy, unrestrained and unlearned, yet most outstandingly courageous.”

349e

“Hold it there,” said I, “for it is worth investigating what you are saying. Do you assert that courageous people are daring, or something else?”

“Yes, and impulsive enough to go where most people are afraid to go,” he said.

“Come now, would you say that excellence is something noble? And do you offer yourself as a teacher of this on the basis that it is noble?”

“Yes, it is utterly noble, unless I am a madman anyway,” he replied.

“So,” I asked, “does it involve a base aspect and a noble aspect, or is it wholly noble?”

“Surely it is wholly noble, to the greatest extent possible.”

350a

“Now, do you know what people dive daringly into wells?”

“I do. I know that they are the divers.”

“Is it because they have knowledge, or for some other reason?”

“Because they have knowledge.”

“And who are daring when it comes to fighting on horseback? Is it the horsemen or the nonhorsemen?”

“The horsemen.”

“And when it comes to light infantry, is it the light infantrymen or the others?”

350b

“It is the light infantrymen,” he replied. “And if this is the answer you are looking for, in all other cases those with knowledge are more daring than those without knowledge, and they themselves are more daring after they have learned than they were before.”

“But have you, on occasion, seen people who lack knowledge of all these who are daring in respect of each of them?”

“I have indeed,” he replied, “excessively daring too.”

“So, are these daring fellows also courageous?”

“In that case,” said he, “courage would be base, since these people are mad.”

“Well,” I asked, “what did you mean by ‘the courageous men’? Wasn’t it the daring men?”

“Yes, and I still say so now,” he replied.

350c

“In that case,” said I, “don’t these people, who are daring in this way, turn out to be insane rather than courageous? And in the other case, aren’t the wisest men also the most courageous since they are the most daring? And based upon this argument, would wisdom be courage?”

350d

“Socrates,” he replied, “you are not remembering properly what I said, or the answer I gave you. When you asked me if the courageous are daring, I agreed. However, I was not also asked if the daring are courageous, for had I been asked that I would have said that they are not all courageous. But in no way have you proved that I was wrong in agreeing to what I did agree, that the courageous are daring. After that, you demonstrate that those who are knowledgeable are themselves more daring than they themselves were before, and more daring than others who are not knowledgeable, and on this basis you presume that courage and wisdom are the same. But proceeding in this manner, you might also presume that strength is wisdom. Yes, proceeding like this, you might first ask me if strong people are capable, and I would agree; next, whether those who know how to wrestle are more capable than those who do not know how to wrestle, and are more capable after they have learned than they themselves were before, and I would agree. Once I had agreed to these, you would be able, using those very same conclusions, to state that according to what I have agreed, wisdom is strength. But I do not agree at all, and I am not agreeing here, that the capable people are strong, even though I agree that the strong people are capable. For capability and strength are not the same. One, capability, arises from knowledge or from madness

or from desire, while the other, strength, comes from the nature and proper nurture of our bodies. Similarly, in the other case, daring and courage are not the same, so it turns out that those who are courageous are daring, even though the daring are not all courageous. For daring arises in people from skill, from desire and from madness, just like capability, while courage arises from the nature and proper nurture of our souls.”

351b

“Protagoras,” I said, “do you agree that some people live their lives well, others badly?”

He agreed.

“And do you think any person would live his life well if he were to live in distress and suffering?”

“No,” he said.

“What if he were to live his life pleasantly to the very end? Don’t you think he would have lived his life well in so doing?”

“I do,” he replied.

351c

“So to live pleasantly is good, while to live unpleasantly is bad.”

“Yes,” he said, “provided, at any rate, one lives one’s life being pleased by what is noble.”

“What about this, Protagoras? Surely you don’t, like most people, refer to some pleasures as bad and some suffering as good? I mean, on the basis that they are pleasant, aren’t they also good on this basis, unless some other consequence emerges from them? And doesn’t the same argument also apply to sufferings? Aren’t they bad insofar as they involve suffering?”

351d

“Socrates,” he replied, “I do not know if I should answer your question in the unqualified manner that you have framed it,

that the pleasures are all good and the sufferings bad. I think, rather, that the safer answer, not only in relation to the present question but in relation to my life in general, is that there are some pleasures that are not good, and in the case of sufferings, some are not bad and some are, and there is a third class that is neither good nor bad.”

351e

“But,” I asked, “don’t you refer to whatever partakes of pleasure or produces pleasure as pleasant?”

“Certainly,” he replied.

“Well, that is what I mean. They are good insofar as they are pleasant. I am asking if pleasure itself is good.”

“As you are always saying, Socrates, let us investigate this, and if the argument seems reasonable, and pleasant and good prove to be the same, we shall be in agreement. If not, we shall argue over it at that stage.”

“So would you like to take control of the investigation, or should I lead it?”

“It is only right that you lead it,” he said, “since you are actually initiating the discussion.”

352a

“Well, then,” said I, “would the following approach clarify the matter for us? It is as if someone, considering a person’s health, or some other of the body’s functions, on the basis of his appearance, were to look at his face and arms and say, ‘Come on now, uncover your chest and back and show them to me, so that I may examine you more thoroughly’. I too have a similar urge in relation to this enquiry. Having seen where you stand in relation to the good and the pleasant, as you state it, I want to say something like this: ‘Come on now, Protagoras, also uncover this aspect of your thought to me. Where do you stand in relation to knowledge?’

352c

“Do you think it is what most people think it is, or do you think otherwise? Most people think knowledge is not really strong or authoritative or fit to rule. They do not think it is like this at all. They think, rather, that very often when a person is endowed with knowledge, it is not the knowledge but something else that rules him, desire at one moment, then pleasure, then pain, sometimes passion, very often fear. They think of knowledge almost as if it were a battle-captured slave who is dragged about by all these other factors. Well now, is this also what you think about knowledge? Or do you think it is something noble that is able to rule a person, and that once a person recognises what is good and what is bad he would never be dominated by anything else and do anything else except what knowledge directs him to do? And is understanding enough to save a person?”

352d

“Socrates,” he replied, “I agree fully with what you are saying. And what is more, it would be disgraceful for me in particular to deny that wisdom and knowledge are the most exalted of all things human.”

352e

“You have expressed that beautifully, and it is true,” I said. “Now, you know that most people are not persuaded by our views, and they maintain that many people who realise what is best do not wish to enact it, even when they can, and that they do something else instead. And when I ask them what exactly causes this behaviour, they say that those who do this, do so because they yield to pleasure and pain, or are overpowered by one of those factors I mentioned just now.”

“Indeed, Socrates,” he replied, “in my view people also say a great deal else that is incorrect.”

353a

“Come on then, join me, and let us try to persuade the people and teach them what this experience of theirs is, the one they describe as yielding to pleasures, and for that reason not doing what is best, even when they realise what is best. Perhaps if we were to tell them that what they are saying is incorrect and that they are speaking falsely, they would ask us, ‘Protagoras and Socrates, if this experience does not involve yielding to pleasure, then what exactly is it? What is it according to you? Tell us.’”

“But, Socrates, why should we consider the opinion that the majority of people hold? They only say whatever happens to occur to them.”

353b

“Well,” said I, “I believe this is significant for us in discovering where courage stands in relation to the other parts of excellence. Now, if you think we should abide by what we agreed earlier, that I should lead in the manner that in my view best clarifies the issue, then please follow my lead.

But if you do not want to, I bid the issue farewell, if that is what you prefer.”

“No, you are quite right,” he said. “Proceed as you have begun.”

353c

“Once again, then,” said I, “if they were to ask us, ‘So what are you saying this is, this experience we termed yielding to pleasures?’ What I would say to them is, ‘Listen, and Protagoras and I shall try to explain it to you. Don’t you good people say that this happens in situations where, for instance, you are overpowered, as so often happens, by the pleasures of food and drink or sexual gratification, and engage in these nevertheless, even though you recognise that they are bad?’”

“They would agree.”

353d

“In that case, you and I would ask them again, ‘In what sense are you saying they are bad? Is it because they provide this pleasure in the moment and because each of them is pleasant, or because some time later they produce disease and poverty, and bring on many other such afflictions? Or even if they bring on none of these afflictions afterwards, but produce only delight, could they be bad anyway, just because they produce delight in some way or other?’ Now, Protagoras, I think they can only reply that they are not bad because of the production of momentary pleasure, but due to the diseases and whatever else arises later.”

353e

“Yes,” said Protagoras, “I believe that most people would give that answer.”

“And in producing disease, don’t they produce distress? And in producing poverty, don’t they produce distress?” I presume they would agree with that.”

Protagoras concurred.

354a

“So, good people, is it your view, as Protagoras and I are saying, that these pleasures are bad only because they end in distress and deprive you of other pleasures?’ Would they agree?”

We both concurred.

“Well, suppose we were to put the opposite question to them. ‘You, good people, who also maintain that what is good can be distressful, are you saying, for example, that physical exercise, military activity or medical treatment brought about through burning, cutting, drugs and fasting are good, even though they are distressful?’ Would they agree?”

He concurred.

354b

“Now, is that why you call them good, because of the extreme pain and the suffering they cause at the time? Or is it because of

the health, bodily vigour, the civic safeguards, the dominion over others, and the wealth that arises from them afterwards?' I presume they would agree."

He concurred.

354c

"And are these good for any other reason than because they end in pleasure, and relieve or avert pain? Or can you think of any other outcome that you might refer to when describing them as good, apart from pleasure and pain?" I think they would say no."

"I think so too," said Protagoras.

"So, do you pursue pleasure as good, and flee from pain as bad?"

He agreed.

354d

"So, this pain is what you regard as bad, and pleasure is what you regard as good. Then, you also say that delight itself is bad whenever it deprives you of greater pleasures than those that the delight affords, or brings on pains greater than the pleasures it contains. Now, if you refer to the delight itself as bad on any other basis, or by referring to any other outcome, you would also be able to tell us what it is. But you cannot."

"No, I don't think they can," said Protagoras.

354e

"Then again, is it the same way with the experience of pain itself? Do you call the experience of pain itself good whenever it relieves you of greater pains than the pain it contains or provides pleasures that exceed the pain? Now, if you refer to any other outcome, whenever you call the experience of pain itself good, you would be able to tell us what it is. But you cannot."

"What you are saying is true," said Protagoras.

“Again, in that case, good people,’ said I, ‘if you should ask me, “Why ever are you saying so much and speaking in so many different ways about this matter?” I would reply, “Please excuse me, but firstly it is not easy to demonstrate what precisely this experience you call ‘yielding to ^{355a} pleasures’ actually is, and secondly, all our examples involve this issue.” But even now it is still possible to retract, if you are somehow able to assert that the good is something other than pleasure, and the bad something other than distress. Or are you satisfied with a life lived pleasantly, a life without pain? If this is satisfactory and you are unable to say that anything is good or bad unless it ends in pleasure or pain, then hear what follows. For I tell you that if this is the case, the argument becomes ridiculous once you state that a person who knows that bad deeds are bad, often enacts them anyway when they can be avoided, as he is led and stricken by pleasures, and also, when you go on to state that a person who knows what is good is not prepared to enact it, because he yields to the pleasures of the moment.’

^{355c}

“And it will be obvious that these arguments are ridiculous, once we stop using lots of names at the same time – pleasure and distress, good and bad. Rather, since it turns out that there are only two things, let’s refer to them by two names, first by good and bad, and after that by pleasure and distress. Then, having assigned the names in this way, we should state that a person who knows that bad deeds are bad, enacts them anyway. So if someone asks us, ‘Why did he do it?’ we shall reply that he yielded. ‘Yielded to what?’ the fellow will ask us. But we are no longer allowed to say that he yields to pleasure, for another word, the good, has been substituted in place of pleasure. So when we are asked the question and we say he yields, he will say, ‘To what?’ and we shall say, ‘By Zeus, to the good.’ Now, if our questioner happens to be arrogant, he will laugh and say, ‘You are describing an absurd state of affairs if someone does

what is bad knowing that it is bad, when he doesn't need to do it, because he yields to what is good'. So he will say, 'Does the bad within you prevail over the good, while being worth more or being worth less?' Obviously, we shall say by way of reply that it is worth less, otherwise the person whom we describe as yielding to pleasures would not have erred. He will probably ask, 'But on what basis is the good worth less than the bad, or the bad than the good? Is there any basis other than one being larger and the other smaller, or one being more numerous and the other less so?' We shall be unable to offer any alternatives to this. 'It's obvious, then,' he will say, 'that by this "yielding" you mean getting less good in place of more bad.'

356a

"So in the case of these names, that is the outcome. Let us then substitute the names once more and apply pleasure and distress to those same things. And we would then state that a person enacts what we previously referred to as bad – but should now refer to as distressful – knowing that it is distressful, having yielded to pleasures which obviously are not worthy of victory. Apart from mutual excess or deficiency, is there any other way that pleasure is worth less than pain? And these involve pleasure and pain becoming larger and smaller than one another, or more numerous and less numerous, or more intense and less intense. For suppose someone were to say, 'But, Socrates, the pleasure of the moment differs greatly from the pleasure and pain that will come later', I would reply, 'Is there any other way they could differ than in pleasure and in pain? Indeed, there is no other way they can differ. Rather, just like a person who is good at weighing, you take the pleasures and the pains, together with their proximity or remoteness, place them in the balance, and state which weighs more. So, if you are weighing pleasures against pleasures, the greater and more numerous are always chosen. If it is pains against pains, the lesser and fewer are always chosen. If it is pleasures against

pains, you adopt the course of action in which the distress is exceeded by the pleasure, whether the near exceeds the far or the far exceeds the near. And if the pleasures are exceeded by the distress, the action is not to be performed.’ So I would say, ‘Good people, isn’t this how matters stand?’ And I know they would be unable to say otherwise.”

356c

Protagoras also agreed with that.

“In this circumstance, I shall say, ‘I have a question for you. Do the same objects appear larger to you when they are nearer, and smaller when far away, or is this not the case?’”

“They will agree.”

“And does the same go for their thickness or the quantity of them? And are equal sounds louder when nearer, and fainter when they are far away?”

“They would agree.”

356d

“Now, if our welfare consisted in this, in enacting or adopting whatever has a large measure, and avoiding and not enacting whatever has a small measure, what would the salvation of our lives prove to be? Would it be skill in measurement or the power of appearance? Or is it the latter power that sets us astray and makes us change our views back and forth so often, and regret our actions, and our choices of greater and lesser; while measurement, for its part – would it have rendered this illusion powerless, and by revealing the truth would it have made the soul peaceful, abiding in the truth, and would it have saved our life? So in view of this, would the people agree that the skill of measurement would save us, or would it be a different one?”

356e

“Measurement,” he agreed.

357a

“What if the salvation of our life lay in the selection of odd and even, and when we should rightly choose the greater and when the lesser, either in relation to themselves or to one another, whether near or far away? What would save our life? Wouldn’t it be knowledge, indeed some form of measurement, since this skill deals with excess and deficiency? And since it involves odd and even, what could it be but arithmetic? Would the people agree with us or not?”

Protagoras also thought they would agree.

357b

“So be it, good people, but since the salvation of our life has turned out to lie in the right selection of pleasure and pain, of more numerous and less numerous, larger and smaller, far and near, firstly, isn’t it the case that measurement is an enquiry into their excess and deficiency, or their equality in relation to one another?”

“It must be.”

“Then measurement must presumably be a skill and knowledge.”

“They will concur.”

357c

“Well, we shall consider on another occasion what this skill and knowledge itself is. The fact that it is knowledge will suffice for the demonstration that Protagoras and I must present in answer to your question. You asked a question, if you recall, when we two agreed that nothing is more powerful than knowledge, and wherever it resides it always dominates over pleasure and all the other factors. You, in contrast, maintained that pleasure often dominates even the man who knows, and as we did not agree with you, you proceeded to ask us, ‘Protagoras and Socrates, if this experience does not consist in yielding to

pleasure, then what precisely is it? And what do you say that it is?

357d

Tell us.'

357e

"If, at the time, we had then replied immediately that it is ignorance, you would have laughed at us. But if you laugh at us now, you will be laughing at yourselves too. For you have actually agreed that it is through deficiency of knowledge that those who err in their choice of pleasures and pains, which correspond to good and bad, fall into error. And later on you agreed that the deficiency is not just deficiency of knowledge, but of knowledge of measurement, and I presume you yourselves know that an action performed in error, without knowledge, is performed in ignorance. Consequently, that is what this yielding to pleasure is, the greatest ignorance, which Protagoras here claims to cure, as do Prodicus and Hippias. But because you do not regard this as ignorance but as something else, you do not send your children to those who teach this, these sophists here, nor do you go to them yourselves because it is not teachable. You care instead for money, and you will not give it to these teachers, so you fare badly in your private and public lives.

358a

"These then are the answers we would have given to most people. And now, along with Protagoras, I am asking you, Hippias and Prodicus, do you think I am speaking the truth or speaking falsely? Let us involve the two of you in the argument."

It seemed to everyone, without reservation, that what had been said was true.

358b

“So, you agree,” said I, “that pleasure is good and distress is bad. And I am avoiding Prodicus’ distinctions between words, for whether you say pleasure is enjoyment or delight or however else you may enjoy assigning names of this sort, good Prodicus, please answer my question, as it is intended.”

Prodicus laughed at this and he agreed, as did the others.

“Well, gentlemen,” said I, “what about all actions towards this end, towards living pleasantly and painlessly – aren’t they all noble? And is a noble deed good and beneficial?”

They agreed.

358c

“So, if it is the case,” said I, “that the pleasant is good, no one who knows or believes that other actions are better than those he is enacting, and can enact, then proceeds to enact them anyway, when he can enact what is better. Nor is yielding to oneself anything other than ignorance, nor is controlling oneself anything other than wisdom.”

They all agreed.

“What about this? Would you say that ignorance consists in holding a false opinion and in labouring under falsehood in relation to matters of great importance?”

This too was agreed upon by everyone.

358d

“Then surely no one goes willingly to what is bad, or what they regard as bad. Nor, it seems, is it in human nature to do so, to wish to go to what you regard as bad instead of what is good. And when compelled to choose one or the other of two bad things, will anyone choose the greater if he is allowed to have the lesser?”

All this was agreed by all of us.

“Well now,” said I, “do you use the terms dread and fear? And do you use them as I do? I am directing this question to you, Prodicus. I say that whether you call it dread or fear, it is some expectation of bad.”

358e

Protagoras and Hippias thought that this is what they are, but Prodicus thought this was dread, but not fear.

“Well, that makes no difference, Prodicus,” I said. “My point is as follows. If what has been said previously is true, will any person wish to go to whatever he dreads if he is allowed to go to what he does not dread? Or is this impossible, from what has been agreed? For we have agreed that whatever he dreads, he regards as bad, and no one willingly goes to or takes hold of what they regard as bad.”

359a

Everyone thought so too.

“Then, Prodicus and Hippias,” said I, “based on these conclusions, Protagoras here should offer us a defence of the answer he gave at first, not the very first one though, where he said there are five parts of excellence, each dissimilar to the other one, each having its own particular power.

359b

That is not the answer I mean. No, it is what he said later. For he said that four of them are fairly similar to one another, while one, courage, differs greatly from the others, and he told me I would recognise this from the following piece of evidence: ‘Indeed, Socrates, you will find people who are utterly irreverent, unjust, unrestrained and unlearned, and yet utterly courageous, and you may appreciate from this fact that courage differs considerably from the other parts of excellence’.

359c

“I was immediately surprised by this response at the time, and I am even more surprised now that I have gone through these

issues with you. Accordingly, I asked him if he calls the courageous people daring, and he said, 'Yes, and impulsive too'. "Do you remember giving that answer, Protagoras?" I asked.

He agreed.

"Come on, then," said I, "tell us. Towards what are the courageous people impulsive? Are they the very things towards which cowards are impulsive?"

"No," he replied.

"They are different then."

"Yes," he replied.

"Do the cowards go for daring exploits, while the courageous go for exploits that are dreaded?"

"That is what people say, Socrates."

359d

"That is true," said I, "but I am not asking you that. I am asking what you say the courageous are impulsive towards. Are they impulsive towards the dreaded exploits in the belief that they should be dreaded, or towards exploits that need not be dreaded?"

"Well," he said, "this was demonstrated to be impossible just now by the arguments you presented."

"That is also true," said I. "And so, if this demonstration was correct, no one embarks upon what in his view should be dreaded, since yielding to oneself was found to be ignorance."

He agreed.

359e

"In that case, everyone, cowards and courageous alike, embark upon daring exploits, and in that respect anyway, both cowards and courageous go for the same things."

“And yet, Socrates,” he said, “what the cowards embark upon and what the courageous embark upon are completely opposite. For instance, the courageous are willing to go to war, while cowards are not.”

“And is it noble to go or is it shameful?”

“It is noble,” he replied.

“Therefore, since it is noble, we have agreed previously that it is good, for we agreed that all noble actions are good.”

“That is true,” he said, “and I am always of that view.”

360a

“You are right about that anyway,” said I. “But which of them are you saying is unwilling to go to war, although it is noble and good?”

“The cowards,” he replied.

“And since it is noble and good, isn’t it also pleasant?”

“Well, that is what has been agreed,” he replied.

“So, are the cowards knowingly unwilling to go to what is nobler, better and more pleasant?”

“But if we agree to this as well,” he replied, “we are undermining what we agreed previously.”

“And what about the courageous?” I asked. “Don’t they go to the nobler, the better and the more pleasant?”

“It is necessary to agree,” he replied.

360b

“Now, on the whole, when courageous people are afraid, their fears are not disgraceful, are they?”

Nor is their daring any disgrace either, is it?”

“That is true,” he said.

“And if they are not disgraceful, aren’t they noble?”

He agreed.

“And if they are noble, are they good?”

“Yes.”

“And the cowards, the insolent and the madmen, aren’t their fears, by contrast, disgraceful? And isn’t their daring disgraceful too?”

He agreed.

“And is their daring disgraceful and bad because of anything else except folly and ignorance?”

360c

“That is the case,” he said.

“Well then, do you refer to that because of which cowards are cowards, as cowardice or courage?”

“I call it cowardice,” he replied.

“And didn’t it turn out that they are cowards because of ignorance of what should be dreaded?”

“Certainly,” he replied.

“So, are they cowards because of this ignorance?”

He agreed.

“And you agree that they are cowards because of cowardice?”

He concurred.

“Therefore, would ignorance of what should be dreaded and not dreaded be cowardice?”

He nodded his head.

360d

“And yet,” said I, “courage is the opposite of cowardice.”

He agreed.

“Now, isn’t wisdom, in relation to what should be dreaded and not dreaded, the opposite of the ignorance thereof?”

He still nodded his head at this too.

“And ignorance of these is cowardice?”

At this point he nodded with extreme reluctance.

“So, is courage wisdom, wisdom in relation to what should be dreaded and not dreaded, since it is the opposite of the ignorance thereof?”

He was no longer even prepared to nod at this stage, and he kept quiet. And I went on to say, “What is this, Protagoras? Will you not answer my question one way or the other?”

“Finish it yourself,” he said.

360e

“I have only one question left to ask you. Does it still seem to you, as it did at the outset, that there are some people who are completely ignorant and yet utterly courageous?”

“Socrates,” he said, “you seem to have a thirst for victory. You want me as your respondent, so, to gratify you, I say that from what has been agreed, that seems impossible to me.”

361a

“I am not,” said I, “asking you all these questions from any other motive than a wish to investigate how exactly matters stand in relation to excellence, and what precisely this is, this excellence. For I know that once this has become obvious, the issue on which you and I have each made such long-drawn-out speeches – you claiming that excellence can be taught, me saying that it cannot – would best be clarified.

361b

“And it seems to me as if the recent outcome of our discussions is just like a person, accusing us and mocking us, and if it were to take on a voice it would say, ‘Socrates and Protagoras, how strange you are! You, Socrates, who were saying earlier that excellence is not teachable, are now, in eager opposition to yourself, trying to demonstrate that all sorts of things are knowledge – justice, self-control, courage. But that is the best way to show that excellence can be taught. For if excellence was anything else except knowledge, as Protagoras attempted to assert, it would clearly be unteachable. But if excellence now turns out to be knowledge wholly, as you are so eager to prove, Socrates, it will be a wonder if it is not teachable. Protagoras, for his part, who was then proposing that it is teachable, now seems keen to make the opposite case, that excellence has turned out to be almost anything at all rather than knowledge. And on this view, it would hardly be teachable.’

361d

“Now, Protagoras, when I behold all these matters in such terrible disarray, I am most eager to have them properly clarified. And once we have been through them all, I would like us also to tackle the question of what excellence is and then come back to investigate whether it is teachable or not. This is in case Epimetheus might also trip us up here, and trick us, just as he did when he overlooked humanity in the story you told us about the distribution of gifts. Now, in that story, Prometheus pleased me more than Epimetheus. So, having recourse to him, displaying forethought in relation to my entire life, I occupy myself with all of these matters. And if you are willing, as I said at the outset, I would be delighted to investigate them comprehensively along with you.”

361e

And Protagoras replied, “Socrates, I can only praise your eagerness and the way you concluded the argument. In fact, I do not think I am, in any sense, a bad person, and I am the least

envious of men, since I have actually said to many people that I admire you much more than anyone else I have met, and far more than anyone else of your age. And I say that I would not be surprised if you were to join the ranks of men who are highly regarded for their wisdom. We shall go over these issues on another occasion, whenever you wish, but it is time now to turn to something else.”

362a

“Well,” said I, “if that is how it seems to you, that is what must be done. In fact, it was time for me to depart a while ago for that appointment I mentioned, but I stayed in order to oblige the noble Callias.”

Having said all this and heard all this, we departed.

NOTES

1. Alcibiades, the son of Clinias, was a famous and notorious politician and general, and a close associate of Socrates.
2. *Iliad* xxiv.348, *Odyssey* x.279.
3. Abdera was a flourishing Greek city in Thrace, on the north coast of the Aegean.
4. Protagoras of Abdera was an influential sophist and teacher of rhetoric.
5. The Hippocrates mentioned here is known only from this dialogue.
6. Callias was the son of the richest man in Greece, Hipponicus. He squandered the fortune he inherited, but remained active in Athenian political life.
7. Hippias was a diplomat, polymath and a famous and successful sophist.
8. Prodicus of Ceos was a contemporary of Socrates. Plato often mentions him and his insistence on the correct use of words.
9. The six men mentioned were prominent Athenians between the ages of 17 and 27. Paralus and Xanthippus were the sons of Pericles, Athens' leading statesman. Pericles' first wife later married Callias' father. Charmides was Plato's maternal uncle, who was eventually associated with the Thirty Tyrants. He is immortalised in Plato's eponymous dialogue. Philippides came from a wealthy family. Nothing more is known about Antimoerus.
10. Orpheus, the mythical singer, charmed not only rational beings, but also birds, fish, wild beasts, trees and rocks.
11. *Odyssey* xi.601.
12. Both Eryximachus, who was a physician, and his friend Phaedrus are speakers in Plato's *Symposium*. Phaedrus is also depicted in the dialogue that bears his name. Andron was a politician.
13. *Odyssey* xi.582.
14. Pausanias and Agathon, a successful tragedian, were long-term lovers who eventually left Athens to live in Macedonia. Adimantus, son of Cepis, is unknown, but assumed to be an Athenian. Adimantus, son of Leucolophides, was an Athenian general.
15. Critias was a member of the oligarchic party and leader of the Thirty Tyrants.

16. The instrument referred to here, the *aulos*, was a single-reeded instrument like a clarinet, or a double-reeded one like an oboe.
17. Ariphron is the brother of Pericles.
18. Prometheus was the champion and benefactor of mankind to whom he gave fire. His name means 'forethought'. Epimetheus is his brother, and his name means 'afterthought'.
19. The Lenaeon festival of Dionysus was celebrated in Athens, with contests chiefly in comedy.
20. In Attic comedy and oratory, these two figures served as paradigms of unscrupulous deceit.
21. Pittacus was ruler of Mytilene in Lesbos and was counted among the Seven Sages.
22. *Iliad* xxi.308-9.
23. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 289-292.
24. This is a complete list of the Seven Sages of Greece who were famous teachers, lawmakers and revered thinkers.
25. *Iliad* x.224.

Republic

ΠΟΛΙΤΕΙΑ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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narrator: SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

persons in the dialogue:

GLAUCON *Plato's brother*

POLEMARCHUS *son of Cephalus*

UNNAMED SLAVE *from Polemarchus' household*

ADIMANTUS *Plato's brother*

THRASYMACHUS *a rhetorician and diplomat from Chalcedon*

CLITOPHON *an oligarchic political leader*

CEPHALUS *from Sicily, a successful shield manufacturer in the Piraeus*

scene: on the road to Athens during the Bendis festival / at the house of Polemarchus in the Piraeus

BOOK I

327a

I went down yesterday to the Piraeus with Glaucon, the son of Ariston,¹ to offer my prayers to the goddess,² and also because I wanted to see how they would conduct the festival, since they were celebrating it for the first time. Now, although I thought the procession of the local people was beautiful indeed, ^{327b} the one that the Thracians put on seemed to suit the occasion just as well. Having offered our prayers and seen what we had come to see, we departed for the city. Then, as we were heading homewards, Polemarchus, the son of Cephalus, ordered his slave to run after us and order us to wait, and once the slave had caught hold of my cloak from behind, he said, "Polemarchus is ordering you to wait." So I turned around and asked where the man himself was. "He is coming up behind me," he replied. "Just wait." "Wait we will," said Glaucon.

327c

And a little later Polemarchus arrived, with Glaucon's brother Adimantus,³ Niceratus, the son of Nicias, and some others, apparently coming from the procession. Then Polemarchus

said, "Socrates, I assume you two are heading back to the city and leaving us." "Not a bad assumption," said I.

328a

"Well," said he, "do you see how many of us there are?" "Of course I do." "Then," said he, "you should either grow stronger than all of these men, or stay here." "Is there not another option?" said I. "Could we not persuade you that you should let us leave?" "And would you be able to persuade us," said he, "if we were not listening to you?" "Not at all," replied Glaucon. "Then you should presume that we will not listen." And Adimantus said, "Well, do you not know that towards evening there will be a torch race on horseback in honour of the goddess?" "On horseback?" said I. "That is novel indeed. Will they carry torches and pass them to one another whilst racing their horses? Is this what you mean?"

328b

"That is it," said Polemarchus. "And what is more, they will be performing an all-night festival that will be worth seeing. Yes, we are going to go out after supper and watch the night festival, and lots of young people will be with us there, and lots of conversation too. So stay, you really must." And Glaucon said, "It seems we should stay." "Well, if that is how it seems," said I, "that is what we must do."

328c

So we went to Polemarchus' house, and there we met Polemarchus' brothers, Lysias⁴ and Euthydemus, and indeed Thrasymachus the Chalcedonian, Charmantides the Paeonian, and Clitophon,⁵ the son of Aristonymus.⁶ Polemarchus' father, Cephalus,⁷ was also in there and he seemed very old to me, as it was indeed some time since I had seen him. He was seated upon a sort of seat with a cushion, with his head in garlands because he had just performed a sacrifice in the courtyard. So we sat down beside him, for some seats were arranged there in a circle.

328d

Now, as soon as Cephalus saw me, he greeted me and said, “Socrates, you do not often come down to the Piraeus to see us, but you should. Yes, if I were still able to make my way to the city easily there would be no need for you to come here, since we could go to you. But nowadays you should come here more frequently since I must say that for me, at least, as the other pleasures, the bodily ones, lose their intensity, the desires and pleasures associated with discussions increase all the more. So you must do this. Be a companion to these young men and visit us here frequently, as though we were your friends and closest kin.”

328e

“Very well, Cephalus,” said I. “In fact, I enjoy conversing with people who are very old. I think we need to learn from them, as though they had traversed a road on which we too will surely have to proceed. What is it like? Is it rough and difficult or is it easy and smooth? What is more, I would love to find out from you how you see this, since you are already at the time of life that the poets call ‘old age’s threshold’.⁸ Is life difficult? Or how do you describe it?”

329a

“I will tell you, by Zeus, Socrates,” said he, “how it looks to me. Yes, some of us, men of our age, often gather together in accordance with the old proverb ‘like to like’.⁹ Now, when we gather, most of us moan, as we long for the lost pleasures of youth and reminisce about love-making, drinking parties and feasts, and whatever goes along with this sort of thing, and we get distressed as though we had been deprived of something important, and that then we lived well but now we are not even alive.

329b

Some bewail the contemptuous treatment of old age by their own kinfolk, and so they go on about the amount of trouble old age causes them. But I think, Socrates, that these people are

blaming the wrong cause. For if this were the cause, I would also have been affected in the very same way, as far as old age is concerned, and so would everyone else who had reached this stage of life. But I have already met others who are not in this predicament, and indeed when someone asked the poet, Sophocles,¹⁰ in my presence, ‘How are you getting on, Sophocles, when it comes to making love? Are you still able to have intercourse with a woman?’ And he replied, ^{329c} ‘Mind what you say, my man. I am glad beyond measure to have escaped this. It is like escaping from a raving and savage slave master.’ I thought at the time that he expressed this quite well, and I still think so now.

^{329d}

For all in all, with old age comes much peace, and a freedom from this sort of thing. When the desires cease their strain and relax, what Sophocles described really does come to pass. It is a release from a whole host of maniacal slave masters. But in these situations, and in the case of problems with family members, there is only one explanation, and it is not old age, Socrates, but the manner of the people. If they are orderly and contented, then old age is wearisome, but in measure. If not, then for someone of this sort, old age, Socrates, and youth too, turn out to be difficult.”

^{329e}

Well, I was delighted with him for saying all this, and because I wanted him to say more I drew him out by asking, “Cephalus, I think that when you say this, most people do not accept your answer. They think, rather, that you bear your old age with ease, not because of your manner but because you have acquired a lot of wealth, for they say that wealthy people have consolation in abundance.” “What you say is true,” said he. “They do not accept it and they do have a point, but not as much as they imagine. Yet the response of Themistocles¹¹ puts this nicely. He was being reviled ^{330a} by the man from Seriphos,

who said that Themistocles was not well regarded because of himself, but because of his city. He replied that he himself would not have become famous had he been from Seriphos, nor would that other man had he been from Athens. And the same argument applies to those who are not wealthy and bear old age with difficulty. A reasonable man would not bear old age accompanied by poverty with much ease, nor would an unreasonable man who had become wealthy ever become content with himself.” “Cephalus,” said I, “did you inherit most of what you have or did you acquire it yourself?”

330b

“Are you asking what I have acquired, Socrates? As a money-maker, I am sort of midway between my grandfather and my father. For my grandfather, whose name I bear, having inherited about as much wealth as I have now acquired, made many times as much as this again. Then my own father, Lysanias, reduced the wealth below its present value, while I would be pleased if I could leave just as much as I inherited to these lads here, and a little more besides.”

330c

“The reason I ask,” said I, “is because you do not seem to be extremely fond of money, and this is in general the case with those who have not acquired the money themselves, while those who have acquired it are twice as attached to it as anyone else. Indeed, just as poets are fond of their own poems, and fathers of their sons, those who make money are serious about money in the same way, seeing it as a production of their own, and also, like everyone else, because of its usefulness. So they are difficult people to be with, since they are not prepared to speak positively of anything except wealth.” “That is true,” he said.

330d

“It certainly is,” said I. “But tell me something else. What do you think is the greatest good you have enjoyed from the

acquisition of so much wealth?" "What I say," he replied, "would probably not persuade many people. For mark my words, Socrates," said he, "once someone begins to think he is about to die, fears and concerns occur to him about issues that had not occurred to him previously. For the stories told about people in Hades, that someone who has acted unjustly whilst here must pay a penalty when he arrives there, ^{330e} stories that were laughable before then torment his soul at that stage, for fear they might be true. And he himself, either on account of weakness born of old age or because of being, in a sense, already closer to whatever is there, has a better view of this, and so he becomes full of foreboding and fear, and he then starts thinking about this and considering whether he has done any injustice to anyone. Someone who discovers that he himself has done a lot of injustice during his life often awakens from sleep, terrified, like a child, and he lives his life in anticipation of evil. While to someone who is aware in himself of nothing unjust, a pleasant, good anticipation is ever present, 'a nurse in his old age', as Pindar says.¹² Yes, Socrates, the poet expressed this in a delightful manner, explaining that for someone who has spent his life in justice and holiness: *Sweet anticipation accompanies him / Fostering his heart, a nurse in his old age, / Chief ruler of mortal thought / With its many twists and turns.*

^{331a}

"He puts it so well. Truly wonderful! So in this respect, I propose that the acquisition of money is most worthwhile, not for everybody, but for the reasonable man. Indeed, the possession of wealth has a major role to play in ensuring that one does not cheat or deceive someone intentionally or, again, depart to that other world in fear because some sacrifices are still owed to a god, or some money to another person. Now, it also has many other uses, and yet setting one against the other, I would propose, Socrates, that this is not the least significant purpose for which wealth is most useful to a man of intelligence."

331b

“That is most beautifully expressed, Cephalus,” said I. “But this thing itself, justice, shall we say without qualification that it is truthfulness, and giving back what has been taken from someone else? Or can these very actions sometimes be performed justly and sometimes unjustly? For instance, if someone took weapons from a friend when the man was of sound mind, and he then went mad and asked for them back, everyone would, presumably, agree that one should not give them back, and that the person returning them would not be just. Nor again would the person who was prepared to speak the entire truth to someone in such a condition be just either.” “That is right,” said he.

331c

“So this is not a definition of justice: to speak the truth and give back what one has taken.” “It certainly is, Socrates,” said Polemarchus, interrupting, “at least if we are to believe Simonides.”¹³ “Yes, indeed,” said Cephalus, “I am now handing the argument over to you, since it is time for me to look after the rituals.” “Am I not the inheritor of whatever is yours in any case?” said Polemarchus. “You certainly are,” he said with a laugh, and with that he left for the rituals.

331d

“Then tell me,” said I, “you, the inheritor of the argument, what do you say Simonides says, and says correctly, about justice?” “That it is just,” said Polemarchus, “to give back what is owed to each person. In saying this he is, in my view, expressing it nicely.” “Well,” said I, “it certainly is not easy to disbelieve Simonides, for he is a wise and divine man. But although you probably appreciate what precisely he is saying, Polemarchus, I do not understand it. For he is obviously not speaking about what we were describing earlier: giving back something that has been deposited to anyone at all who is not of sound mind when he asks for it, although what has been deposited is presumably

owed. Is this so?" "Yes."

331e

"Yet it should not be given back, under any circumstances, when someone of unsound mind asks for it." "True," said he. "Then when Simonides says that giving back what is owed is just, he is not referring to this sort of thing but to something else." "Something else indeed, by Zeus," said he, "for he thinks that what friends owe to friends is to do them some good, and nothing bad."

332a

"I understand," said I. "Whoever gives gold back to someone who deposited it is not giving back what is owed if the giving back or the taking turns out to be harmful, and the one who hands it over and the one who gives it back are friends. Is this what Simonides means, according to you?" "Yes, certainly."

332b

"What about enemies? Should we give back whatever happens to be owed to them?" "Entirely so," he replied, "whatever is owed to them. And what is owed from one enemy to another one, and what is appropriate too, is something bad."

332c

"In that case," said I, "it seems Simonides was speaking in riddles, as poets do, when he spoke of what is just. For apparently he had in mind that what is just is this: 'giving back what is appropriate to each'. But to this he gave the name 'what is owed'." "What else do you think?" said he. "By Zeus," said I, "if someone had asked him, 'Simonides, the skill called medicine is one that gives back. But what is owed and appropriate, and to what does it give this?' What answer do you think he would have given us?" "Obviously," said he, "it is the skill that gives medicines, food and drink to bodies." "What about the skill called cookery? What is owed and appropriate, and to what does it give this?"

332d

“It is the one that gives seasoning to dishes.” “Very well. And the skill that could be called justice gives what to what?” “Socrates,” said he, “if we are to adhere at all to what we were just saying, it is the skill that gives benefit back to friends and harm back to enemies.” “So is he saying that justice is doing good to friends and bad to enemies?” “I think so.” “When it comes to disease and health, who is most capable of doing good to sick friends and harm to sick enemies?” “A physician.”

332e

“And who is most capable of doing so to those who are sailing and facing the danger of the sea?” “A ship’s pilot.” “And what about the just man? In what activity or in relation to what task is he most capable of benefiting friends and harming enemies?” “In waging war and in forming alliances, in my opinion at least.” “Very well. Now, to those who are not sick, dear Polemarchus, a physician is of no use.” “True.” “And a ship’s pilot is of no use to those who are not sailing.” “Yes.” “So a just man too is of no use to those who are not waging war.” “That is not really how it seems to me.”

333a

“Then justice is also useful in time of peace?” “Yes, it is useful.” “And so is farming, is it not?” “Yes.” “For providing us with the fruits of the earth?” “Yes.” “And so too is shoe-making.” “Yes.” “For providing us with shoes. I presume that is what you would say?” “Entirely so.” “And what about justice? What would you say it is useful for in time of peace? For the use of or the acquisition of what?” “For contractual arrangements, Socrates.”

333b

“And by contractual arrangements, do you mean partnerships or something else?” “Yes, partnerships indeed.” “Well, is the just man also a good and useful partner when it comes to placing draughts on a board, or is it the draughts-player?” “It is the draughts-player.” “But when it comes to the placement of

bricks and stones, is the just man a more useful and better partner than the house builder?" "Not at all." "Well, in what sort of partnership is the just man a better partner than the harpist, in the same way that the harpist is a better partner than the just man when it comes to striking the strings?" "Well, in my opinion, it is when it comes to money."

333c

"Except perhaps when it comes to spending the money, Polemarchus. When it is necessary, in partnership, to buy or sell a horse, then I presume a horse-trainer is better. Is this so?" "Apparently." "And when it is a ship, is a shipwright or ship's pilot better?" "So it seems." "So, when is the just man more useful than others? When the silver or gold is to be used in partnership for what purpose?" "When it is to be placed on deposit and kept safe, Socrates." "Do you mean when no use is to be made of it and it is to lie idle?" "Entirely so."

333d

"So when money is not used, that is when justice is useful to it?" "Quite likely." "And when a pruning hook is to be guarded, justice is useful both in partnership and privately, but when it is to be used, the skill of the vine-dresser is useful?" "Apparently." "Will you also say that when a shield or a lyre are to be guarded and not used, justice is useful, but when they are to be used, military or musical skill is useful?" "It must be so." "And, indeed, in all other cases, is justice of no use when it comes to using each of them, and is it useful when not using them?" "Quite likely."

333e

"Well, my friend, justice would not really be of any great consequence if it turned out to be useful only for things that are not being used. But let us consider this. Consider the person who is most skilled at landing a blow in a fight, whether in a boxing match or in any other situation. Is he not also the one who is most skilled at guarding against a blow?" "Entirely so."

“And is someone who is skilled in guarding against disease also the one who is most skilled at engendering it without being noticed?” “Well, I think so.”

334a

“Then again, if someone is a good guardian of an army, is the same person also good at stealing the enemy’s plans and manoeuvres?” “Entirely so.” “Then someone who is a skilled guardian of something is also a skilled thief of that?” “So it seems.” “So, if the just man is clever at guarding money, he will be clever at stealing it too?” “That is what this argument indicates, at any rate,” said he.

334b

“Then, it seems the just man has turned out to be a kind of thief, and it is quite likely that you learned this from Homer. In fact, he admires Odysseus’ maternal grandfather, Autolycus, and says he surpassed all of humanity in theft and in perjury.¹⁴ So it seems that justice, according to you, Homer, and Simonides, is a kind of theft, although it is for the benefit of friends and to the detriment of enemies. Is this not what you meant?” “No, by Zeus,” he said. “In fact, I no longer know what I meant. And yet, I am still of the opinion that justice benefits friends and harms enemies.”

334c

“And by someone’s friends, do you mean those who seem to that person to be worthy people, or those who actually are so, even though they do not seem so? And does the same apply to enemies?” “Well, someone is likely to be friendly towards people he believes to be worthy, and to hate those he believes to be bad.” “Now, do not people make mistakes about this, so that lots of people seem to them to be worthy when they are not, and vice versa?” “Yes, they make mistakes.” “So to those who make mistakes, are the good people their enemies, while the bad people are their friends?” “Entirely so.” “But in that case is it just, nevertheless, for them to benefit the bad people and to

harm the good people?" "Apparently so."

334d

"And yet, those who are good at any rate are just, and are not the sort of people to act unjustly." "True." "Then according to your argument, it is just to act badly towards those who do no injustice." "Not at all, Socrates," said he. "Indeed, the argument seems to be a bad one." "In that case," said I, "is it just to harm those who are unjust and to benefit those who are just?" "This sounds better than that other conclusion."

334e

"So, Polemarchus, in the many cases where people make mistakes about their fellow men, it will turn out that it is just to harm their friends, for they have bad friends, and on the other hand to benefit their enemies, for their enemies are good. And so we shall be saying the exact opposite of what we said Simonides is saying." "Very much so," said he. "That is how it turns out. But let us make a change, since it is quite likely that we have not defined friend and enemy correctly." "In what way, Polemarchus?" "In saying that someone who seems worthy is a friend." "And how should we change this now?" I asked. "Someone who seems to be, and actually is, worthy is a friend. But someone who seems to ^{335a} be worthy, but is not so, seems to be a friend but is not a friend. And we should make the same proposal in relation to an enemy." "Then, by this argument it seems, the good person will be a friend and the bad person an enemy." "Yes." "Are you asking us to make an addition to our account of what is just? At first we said it was just to do good to a friend and bad to an enemy, but you are now asking us to add to this and say that it is just to do good to a friend who is good, and harm to an enemy who is bad?" "Yes, certainly," he said. "I think that would be a very nice way to express it."

335b

"Now," said I, "is it befitting a just man to harm any person at all?" "Yes, certainly," said he. "He should harm those who are

bad and who are enemies too.” “But when horses are harmed, do they become better or worse?” “Worse.” “And is this in relation to the excellence that belongs to dogs or to horses?” “In relation to the excellence that belongs to horses.” “And when dogs too are harmed, do they not become worse, in the excellence that belongs to dogs and not in the excellence that belongs to horses?” “Necessarily.” “And accordingly, my friend, should we not say that when human beings are harmed, they become worse in terms of human excellence?” “Yes, certainly.”

335c

“And justice, is it not human excellence?” “This too is necessarily so.” “And in that case, human beings who are harmed necessarily become more unjust.” “So it seems.” “Now, are musicians able to make people unmusical by their musicianship?” “Impossible.” “Is it possible for horsemen to turn people into non-horsemen by their horsemanship?” “It is not.” “Well then, can the just men make people unjust by means of their justice? Or, in short, can the good people make people bad by means of their excellence?” “No, that is impossible.”

335d

“Indeed it is, I think, not the function of heat to cool things down, but of its opposite.” “Yes.” “Nor is it the function of dryness to moisten things, but of its opposite.” “Entirely so.” “Nor is it the function of good to do harm, but of its opposite.” “Apparently.” “And the just man is good.” “Entirely so.” “So it is not the function of the just person to harm either a friend or anyone else, Polemarchus. No, that is the function of his opposite, the unjust person.” “I think you are speaking the truth, Socrates,” said he, “entirely so.”

335e

“So, if someone maintains that it is just to give back what is owed to each, and by this he means that harm is owed to enemies by the just man, and benefit is owed to friends, the person saying this was not wise for he did not speak the truth,

since it has become evident to us that there are no circumstances in which it is just to harm anyone.” “I concur,” said he. “Then you and I shall do battle,” said I, “in partnership, if anyone maintains that Simonides or Bias or Pittacus,¹⁵ or any other wise and blessed man, has said so.” “Well, I am ready,” said he, “to be your partner in the battle.”

336a

“But,” I said, “do you know who, it seems to me, is the originator of this maxim, the one that maintains that it is just to benefit one’s friends and harm one’s enemies?” “Who?” he asked. “I think it is a maxim of Periander or Perdiccas or Xerxes or Ismenias the Theban,¹⁶ or some other rich man who thinks he has great power.” “What you say is very true,” said he. “Very well,” said I. “But since it has become evident that this is not justice, or what is just, what else might someone say that it is?”

336b

Now, even while we were conversing, Thrasyarchus made several efforts to take control of the discussion, but he was prevented from doing so by the people sitting beside him who wanted to hear the discussion. But as we had paused, and I had asked this question, he held his peace no longer. Gathering himself up like a wild beast, he came at us as though he would tear us to pieces. Polemarchus and I were panic-stricken with fear, as he roared out in our midst.

336c

“What is this nonsense,” said he, “that has taken hold of you for so long, Socrates? And why are you both fooling around and giving way to one another? Yes, if you really want to know what it is that is just, do not just ask questions or try your best to refute someone when they give you an answer, knowing full well that it is easier to ask questions than to answer them. Answer the question yourself and say what it is that is just according to you. And do not tell me that it is ‘what is needed’ or ‘what ^{336d} is beneficial’ or ‘profitable’ or ‘expedient’ or

‘advantageous’. Just tell me clearly and precisely what it is, for I will not accept your answer if you propose this sort of nonsense.” Now, when I heard him, I was shocked, and looking at him in terror I thought that if I had not seen him before he saw me, I would have been struck dumb. But as it happened, once the argument had begun to make him mad, I looked at him first, and so I was able to answer him, and I ^{336e} said, with a slight tremble in my voice, “Thrasymachus, do not be so harsh with us, for if Polemarchus here and I are making mistakes in considering the argument, rest assured that our mistakes are unintentional. If we were searching for gold we would never give way to one another deliberately in the search, and ruin our chances of finding it. So you certainly should not presume that in searching for justice, something more precious than a lot of gold, we would then give way to one another in this mindless manner and not be serious about bringing it fully to light. Do not make that presumption, my friend. No, in my opinion we lack the ability, so it is surely far more ^{337a} reasonable that you clever people have mercy on us rather than being harsh.” And when he heard this he broke into scornful laughter. “By Heracles,” said he, “there it is, the familiar irony of Socrates. Indeed, I predicted this already. Yes, I told these people that you would not be willing to answer questions and would speak ironically and do anything rather than answer the question someone asked you.” “You are indeed wise, Thrasymachus,” said I. “So you knew full well that if you were to ask someone how much twelve is, and if you were to introduce your question by saying to him, ^{337b} ‘Do not tell me, my man, that twelve is twice six, or three times four, or six times two, or that it is four times three, because I will not accept your answer if you talk such nonsense as this,’ I am sure it is obvious to you that no one could answer your question if you were to put it like that.

^{337c}

But if he responded to you, ‘Thrasymachus, what are you saying? Can I not give a single one of the answers you mentioned? That is amazing! Even if one of them happens to be the answer, should I say something other than what is true? Or what do you mean?’ What would you say to him in reply?” “Well, well,” said he, “so this is like that question of mine!” “There is no reason why not,” said I, “but even if it is not like that but it seems like that to the person you are questioning, do you not think he is likely nonetheless to answer based on how it appears to him, whether we are prohibiting these responses or whether we are not?”

337d

“Is that what you are going to do now?” he said. “Will you give one of those answers that I prohibited?” “I would not be surprised,” said I, “if that is how it seemed to me once I had considered the matter.” “And what if I should present a different answer about justice besides these, and better than all of them? What fate would you deserve?” “The fate that is appropriate to someone who does not know,” said I. “There is no alternative. And presumably it is appropriate that he learn from someone who knows. So this is the fate I deserve to suffer.”

337e

“How sweet you are,” said he. “But as well as learning, you should also pay a fee.” “Yes, when I have the money,” said I. “You have it,” said Glaucon. “If money is an issue speak on, Thrasymachus, since we will all pay for Socrates.” “Yes, I am quite sure you will,” said he, “so that Socrates may arrange things, as usual. He does not answer questions himself, and when someone else answers, he may take hold of an argument and refute it.”

338a

“Best of men,” said I, “how could someone give answers when, in the first place, he does not know nor does he claim to know?

And secondly, even if he does have some thoughts on the matter, he is prohibited from saying what he believes by a man of no mean status? No, it is more reasonable that you speak, since you actually claim to know and to be able to express what you know. So you really must do this. Gratify me by answering the question. Do not hold back, and instruct Glaucon here, and the others too.” Once I had said all this, Glaucon and the others implored him to do what I had asked him to do, and Thrasymachus was obviously eager to speak in order to impress people, since he thought he had a really good answer, but he pretended to be keen that I be the one to answer the question. He ^{338b} finally gave his assent, and then he said, “There it is, the wisdom of Socrates. Although he himself does not want to teach, he goes about learning from others, and he does not even thank them.” “What you are saying is true, Thrasymachus,” said I, “I do learn from others. But when you say I do not give thanks, that is not true, for I give as much as I am able to give. But since I do not have money, I am only able to give praise, and once you give your answer you will know full well, there and then, just how eagerly I praise someone who seems to me to speak well, since I believe you will speak well.”

^{338c}

“Then listen,” said he. “Indeed, I maintain that what is just is nothing else but the ‘advantage of the stronger’. Well, why do you not praise me? You just do not want to.” “I should understand what you are saying first,” said I. “At the moment I still do not know what you mean. You maintain that the advantage of the stronger is just. But what exactly do you mean by this, Thrasymachus? For presumably you are not maintaining that if Polydamas, the pancratiast,¹⁷ is stronger than we are, and it is to his advantage to eat beef for his body, then this food is also advantageous for us weaker folk, and just too?”

^{338d}

“You are loathsome indeed, Socrates,” said he, “and you are interpreting the argument in a sense that does it the most damage.” “Not at all, best of men,” said I. “Just explain what you mean, with greater clarity.” “Do you not know,” said he, “that some cities are governed as tyrannies, some as democracies, others as aristocracies?” “Of course.” “And whatever rules in each city exercises power?” “Entirely so.”

338e

“And each ruling group institutes the laws to its own advantage, democratic laws in the case of a democracy, tyrannical laws in the case of a tyranny, and so on. Having instituted them, they then proclaim that this, what is advantageous to themselves, is just for those over whom they rule and so they punish those who go against this, as lawbreakers who are acting unjustly. So this, best of men, is what I say is just: it is the same in all cities, the advantage ^{339a} of the established ruling group. This presumably holds power, and it follows, if one reasons correctly, that what is just is the same everywhere: the advantage of the stronger.” “I now understand what you are saying,” said I, “and I shall attempt to understand whether it is true or not. So, Thrasymachus, you too have answered that what is advantageous is what is just, even though you prohibited me from giving this answer, and yet the words ‘for the stronger’ were ^{339b} added on to it.” “Yes, a minor addition perhaps,” said he. “It is not yet clear whether it is significant or minor, but it is clear that we should consider whether or not you are speaking the truth. Now, since I too accept that what is just is something advantageous, but you make an addition and say it is the advantage of the stronger, while I do not know, consider it we must.” “Consider it then,” said he. “That is what I shall do,” said I. “Tell me then. Do you not maintain that it is just to obey those who rule?” “Yes, I do.”

339c

“And are the rulers of each city unerring, or are they also capable of making some mistakes?” “Absolutely,” said he. “They are also quite capable of making some mistakes.” “So as they set about instituting the laws, would they not institute some laws correctly, others incorrectly?” “Yes, I think so.” “And what is instituted correctly is to their own advantage, and what is instituted incorrectly is to their disadvantage. Is this what you are saying?” “Just so.” “But whatever they institute must be enacted by those over whom they rule, and this is what is just?” “Of course.”

339d

“Then according to your argument, it is just not only to enact what is advantageous for the stronger, but also the opposite, what is disadvantageous.” “What are you saying?” he replied. “What you are saying, I think, but let us take a better look. Hasn’t it been agreed that when the rulers are directing their subjects to enact something, they sometimes make mistakes about what is best for themselves, yet it is just for the subjects to enact whatever the rulers order? Has this not been agreed?” “Yes, I think so,” said he.

339e

“Then, you must suppose,” I said, “that you also accept that it is just to do what is disadvantageous to those who rule and are stronger, whenever the rulers unintentionally direct what is bad for themselves, since you maintain that it is just for the others to enact what the rulers have directed. So in that case, wisest Thrasymachus, does it not necessarily follow that it is just to do the very opposite of what you are saying? For the weaker have surely been directed to enact what is disadvantageous to the stronger.” “Yes, by Zeus, Socrates,” said Polemarchus, “nothing could be clearer.”

340a

“Yes, if you are to be his witness,” said Clitophon, interrupting. “Why is there need of a witness?” said he. “Indeed,

Thrasymachus himself accepts that although the rulers sometimes direct what is bad for themselves, it is still just for the others to enact this.” “Because, Polemarchus, Thrasymachus posited that to enact the orders of the rulers is just.” “Yes, Clitophon, and he also proposed that the advantage of the stronger is just. And having put both these proposals forward, he went on to admit that the stronger sometimes order the weaker folk, their subjects, to enact what is disadvantageous for themselves. But based upon these admissions, what is advantageous for the stronger would be no more just than what is not advantageous.”

340b

“But,” said Clitophon, “by ‘what is advantageous for the stronger’ he meant what the stronger person believes to be advantageous to himself. This is what is to be enacted by the weaker, and he posited that this is what is just.” “But that is not what he said,” said Polemarchus. “That makes no difference, Polemarchus,” said I. “Rather, if Thrasymachus now means it in this way, let us accept it from him in this way. “So tell me, Thrasymachus, is this what you wanted to say is just, what seems to the stronger to be to the advantage of the stronger, whether it is advantageous or not? Shall we say that this is what you mean?”

340c

“No, not in the least,” said he. “Do you think that I call someone who is making mistakes stronger, at the time he is making the mistakes?” “Yes,” said I, “I did think you meant this when you accepted that those who rule are not unerring, but also make some mistakes.” “That is because,” said he, “you are conducting your arguments unfairly, Socrates. Take an immediate example. Do you call someone who is making mistakes in treating the sick a physician, based on the actual mistake he is making, or someone who makes mistakes in calculating, a calculator at the time he is making a mistake, based on this mistake? No, I 340d

think this is just our manner of speaking. We say the physician makes mistakes, the calculator makes mistakes, and so does the writing teacher. But in fact, I think each of these, insofar as they are what we call them, never makes mistakes. And so, according to this precise account, since you do speak so precisely, none of these practitioners errs. Someone who makes mistakes does so in the absence of knowledge when he is not a practitioner, and so no practitioner, wise person, or ruler, makes mistakes at that time when he is a ruler, even though everyone would say that the physician erred, and so did the ruler. So it ^{340e} is in this sense in which you should understand the answer I gave you a moment ago. But the other account is the most precise. The one who rules, insofar as he is a ruler, does not make mistakes and he unerringly institutes what is best for himself, and this must be enacted by the one who is ruled. And so, as I have been saying from the outset, I say that what is just is enacting what is to the advantage of the stronger.” “Very well, Thrasymachus,” said I. “Do you think I am arguing unfairly?” “Yes, certainly,” he replied.

^{341a}

“Because you think I asked my questions in the way I asked them, as part of a plan to do damage to you in the arguments.” “I actually know this quite well,” he said. “Yes, and you will not get any further for you could not do this damage without my noticing it, nor will you be capable of overpowering me in the argument now that you have been found out.”

^{341b}

“Blessed man,” said I, “I would not even make the attempt! But to avoid something of this sort happening to us all over again, please clarify in which sense you mean ‘the ruler’ and ‘the stronger’. Do you mean the ruler and stronger in the common sense of the words or in the precise sense that you explained just now, who is stronger and whose advantage it will be just for the weaker person to enact?” “The one who is a ruler in the

most precise sense of the word,” said he. “So do damage ^{341c} to that and be unfair if you can – I am asking you for no concessions – but you won’t be able to.” “Do you think,” said I, “that I would be so insane as to attempt to shave the lion, by being unfair to Thrasymachus?” “Well, you made the attempt just now,” said he, “and you came to naught in that case too.” “Enough of this sort of thing,” said I. “But tell me. The physician, in the precise sense you explained earlier, is he a money-maker or someone who treats the sick? And you should speak of someone who really is a physician.” “He is someone who treats the sick,” he replied. “What about a steersman? Is someone who is a steersman, in the correct sense, a sailor or someone who is in charge of sailors?”

^{341d}

“Someone who is in charge of sailors.” “We need not, I believe, take account of the fact that he sails in a ship, nor is he to be called a sailor for that reason. For he is not called a steersman based on his sailing, but based on his skill and the fact that he is in charge of the sailors.” “True,” he said. “Is there not some advantage that belongs to each of these?” “Absolutely.” “And is not the skill naturally directed to this,” I asked, “to seeking out and furnishing what is advantageous to each?” “It is directed to this,” said he. “Now, in each of the skills too, is there any other advantage apart from being as perfect as possible?”

^{341e}

“In what sense are you asking this question?” “It is as if you were to ask me,” said I, “whether it is sufficient that our body be a body, or is it in need of something else besides. I would reply that it does need something else, entirely so, and that is why the skill of medicine has now been invented, because our body is deficient and it is not sufficient that it be like this. So this skill has been provided in order to furnish what is advantageous to this body. Do you think,” said I, “that I would have answered correctly or incorrectly had I said this?” “Correctly,” he replied.

342a

“What about this? Is medicine itself deficient, or is there any other skill that needs some additional excellence, in the way that eyes need sight and ears need hearing, and is there, for this reason, a need for some skill, set over them, that considers what’s advantageous in this respect, and provides it? So too, is there any deficiency in the skill itself, and does each skill need another skill that will consider what’s advantageous to it, and does the one that’s considering this need another skill of this sort, in turn, and is this an unending process? Or will the skill consider what is advantageous ^{342b} to itself? Or does it need neither itself nor another skill to consider what is advantageous in relation to its own deficiency, because there is no deficiency or error present in any skill, nor is it the function of a skill to seek what is advantageous for anything apart from the object of that skill? And is it unblemished and pure, because it is right, as long as each skill is precisely and wholly what it is? And considering that ‘precise’ formulation, is this how matters stand or not?” “So it appears,” he said. “So,” said I, “medicine does not consider what is advantageous to medicine, but to the body.” “Yes,” said he.

342c

“Nor does horsemanship consider what is advantageous to horsemanship, but to horses. Nor does any other skill consider what is advantageous to itself, since it has no additional need. It considers what is advantageous to the object of that skill.” “It appears so,” he replied. “But of course, Thrasymachus, the skills rule over and dominate the objects of those skills.” He agreed to this, but with great reluctance. “So no knowledge at all considers or commands what is to the advantage of the stronger, but what is to the advantage of the weaker, and of whatever is ruled by the knowledge itself.”

342d

In the end he accepted this too, although he did attempt to resist it. Once he had agreed, I said, “So is it not the case that no physician, insofar as he is a physician, considers or commands what is advantageous to the physician rather than to the sick person? For it has been agreed that the physician, in the precise sense, is someone who rules over bodies, but is not a money-maker. Was that not agreed?” He concurred. “Is not the steersman too, in the precise sense, also someone who rules over sailors, but is not a sailor?” He agreed. “So a steersman and ruler of this sort will not consider and command what is advantageous to the steersman, but to the sailor, the person whom he rules over.” He concurred, reluctantly.

342e

“In that case, Thrasymachus,” said I, “no one at all exercising any rulership, insofar as he is a ruler, considers or commands what is advantageous to himself, but to the one he rules over, for the sake of whom he himself exercises his skill. With his gaze fixed upon that, and whatever is advantageous and appropriate to that, he says all that he says and he does all that he does.”

343a

Now, once we had reached this stage in the discussion, and it was apparent to everyone that his argument about what is just had undergone a complete reversal, Thrasymachus, instead of responding said, “Tell me, Socrates, do you have a nurse?” “Why is this?” said I. “Should you not respond rather than asking a question like this?” “Because,” said he, “she overlooks your snivelling and does not wipe your nose though you need it. In any case, with her, you do not even distinguish between shepherds and sheep.” “Why exactly are you saying this?” I asked.

343b

“Because you think the shepherds and the neatherds consider the good of the sheep and the oxen, and fatten them and care for them with a view to something else besides the good of their

masters and themselves. What is more, you imagine that those who rule our cities, those who truly rule, have some other attitude towards those they rule over than the disposition someone might have towards sheep, and that they consider something else, night and day, besides how they will benefit themselves. And when it comes to what is just and justice, what is unjust and injustice, ^{343c} you are so remote that you are unaware that justice and what is just are, in fact, someone else's good, being the advantage of the stronger, of those who rule, and the personal detriment of whoever obeys and is subordinate. But injustice is the opposite, and it rules over the truly simple-minded ^{343d} folk who are just and who, because they are ruled, do what is to the advantage of that stronger man and make that person happy by serving him, without making themselves happy at all. "But, my utterly simple-minded Socrates, you should consider the fact that everywhere the just man has less than the unjust man. Firstly, in contractual arrangements with one another, wherever people like this are in partnership with one another, you would never find that the just man has more than the unjust man when the partnership is ended. No, he has less. Again, in their dealings with the city, when there are taxes to be paid, the just man pays more and the unjust man pays ^{343e} less although they are equally liable. And when there is money to be had one gains nothing while the other gains a lot. And, indeed, whenever either of them holds a position of authority, the just man, even if he suffers no other loss, suffers the deterioration of his personal affairs through neglect, and because he is just he takes no personal advantage of public property. And besides all this he is hated by his family and acquaintances when he is not prepared to afford them any service beyond what is just. But what happens to the unjust man is the opposite of all this. Indeed, I am referring ^{344a} to the person I was speaking of just now, someone who is capable of getting more, on a large scale. That is the person you should

consider if you really want to judge how much more advantageous it is to him, personally, to be unjust rather than just. “But the easiest way of all for you to understand this is by taking the most extreme injustice, that makes the one who has committed the injustice as happy as he can possibly be, and those who have suffered the injustice, and are not prepared to act unjustly, utterly wretched. This is tyranny, which takes, not little by little but all at once by stealth and by force, what does not ^{344b} belong to it, what is sacred and holy, private and public. If someone acts unjustly by enacting a particular part of this extreme injustice, and he is found out, he is penalised and attracts enormous reproach. And, indeed, temple robbers, kidnappers, house-breakers, swindlers and thieves is what they call people who, through crimes of this sort, are unjust in part only. But, when in addition to stealing the wealth of the citizens someone actually kidnaps and enslaves the citizens themselves, instead of these shameful names he is called happy and blessed, not only by those citizens, ^{344c} but by anyone who hears that he has acted in this completely unjust manner. For, those who reproach injustice do not reproach it because they are afraid of doing unjust deeds. No, they are afraid of suffering them. “And so, Socrates, injustice on a sufficiently large scale is stronger, freer and more dominant than justice. And as I said at the outset, what is just is indeed the advantage of the stronger, and what is unjust is profitable and advantageous to oneself.”

^{344d}

Having said all this, Thrasymachus intended to leave, having poured his speech about our ears in a massive flood, like an attendant at the baths. However, the company wouldn't allow him to do so. Rather, they compelled him to stay and provide an argument in support of what he had said. I myself was particularly insistent, and I said, “Heavens, Thrasymachus, after firing off a speech like that, do you intend to take your leave before you provide adequate instruction or before you have

learned whether or not this is how matters ^{344e} stand? Or do you think we are trying to determine some minor issue, rather than a course of life which would enable anyone who pursues it to live the most profitable of lives?" "Indeed," said Thrasymachus, "do I think this is not the case?" "You seem to think so," said I, "or else you do not care about us, nor have you any concern about whether we live worse or better lives, we who are in ignorance about what you claim to know. So, good man, take heart and explain it to us, since you won't fare at all badly if you do a good deed ^{345a} for so many of us. In fact, I must say that I, for my part, am not persuaded, nor do I believe that injustice is more profitable than justice, not even if someone allows it free rein and does not prevent it from doing whatever it wishes. No, my good man, let a man be unjust and able to act unjustly, either by avoiding detection or by open force. Nevertheless, he does not persuade me that injustice is more profitable than justice. Now, there is probably someone else among us, and I am not alone, who is not convinced of this, so do enough to persuade us, blessed man, that we are being ill-advised when we set justice above injustice."

^{345b}

"But how am I going to persuade you?" he asked. "Indeed, if you are not persuaded by what I said just now, what more can I do for you, besides taking the argument and shoving it into your soul?" "By Zeus," said I, "do not do that. No, firstly, you should stand by whatever you said, or if you do change your position do so openly and do not try to deceive us. But at the moment, Thrasymachus, let us look again at the previous examples, because, you see, although you began by defining the physician in the true sense, you no longer thought it necessary later on to be careful and precise ^{345c} about the shepherd in the true sense. Instead, you presume that he fattens the sheep with a view not to what's best for the sheep, but with a view to a banquet, as if he were a dinner guest about to have a feast, or again with a

view to selling them, like a businessman rather than a shepherd. But the skill of shepherding surely does not care for anything else apart from what it has been put in charge of, and how to provide to this what's best, since as long as it does not fall short of being shepherding, whatever belongs to itself has, of course, already been provided to a sufficient extent so that it can be best. Accordingly, I think we need to accept at this stage that all rule, insofar as it ^{345d} is rule, does not consider what's best for anything else except what it rules over and tends upon, whether the rule is exercised in civic or in private matters. But do you think that those who exercise rule in our cities, those who rule in the true sense, do so of their own free will?" "By Zeus," said he, "I do not think it. I know it very well." "But why, Thrasymachus?" said I. "Are you not aware that in the case of the other rulers, no one is prepared of his own free will to exercise rule? Rather, they ask for payment because any benefit accruing from the exercise of rule will accrue, not to themselves, but to those who are ruled. Now, ^{345e} tell me this much. Do we not consistently say that each of the skills is different in virtue of having a different power? And, blessed man, do not give an answer that is contrary to your own opinion, so that we may make some progress." "Yes," said he, "they are different in virtue of this." "Does not each of them provide some benefit of its own to us, a benefit that is not common to them all, medicine providing health, steersmanship providing safety at sea, and so on for the other skills?" "Entirely so."

^{346a}

"And does not wage-earning provide a reward, since that is its power? Or do you call medicine and steersmanship the same skill? Or, if you really want to make a precise distinction, as you proposed, would you be any more inclined to refer to a steersman's skill as medicine if someone acting as a steersman were to become healthy because of the advantages of a sea

voyage?” “Of course not,” he said. “Nor, I believe, would you say this about wage-earning if someone earning wages were to become healthy.” “Of course not.”

346b

“What about this? Would you call medicine wage-earning if someone were to earn a wage whilst healing people?” “I would not,” he said. “Well, did we not agree that the benefit of each skill is particular to that skill?” “I grant that,” said he. “Then whatever benefit all the practitioners obtain in common, they obviously obtain by their common recourse to something else that is the same.” “So it seems,” said he.

346c

“And yet, we maintain that the benefit whereby the practitioners gain a reward comes to them from their recourse to the wage-earning skill.” He agreed reluctantly.

346d

“So, it is not from his own skill that each practitioner has this benefit, whereby he obtains a reward. Rather, if we are to consider this precisely, medicine produces health while wage-earning produces a reward, and although house-building produces a house, wage-earning follows it and produces a reward. And the same goes for all the other skills. Each performs its own function and benefits whatever it is set over, but if a reward were not to accompany the skill, is there any benefit to the practitioner?” “Apparently not,” said he.

346e

“In that case, when he works for nothing, does he not confer any benefit then?” “No, I think he does.” “Therefore, Thrasymachus, this much is obvious by now. No skill or rule furnishes what is beneficial to itself but, as we have been saying for some time, it furnishes and commands what is beneficial to whatever it rules over by considering what is to the advantage of the weaker, but not of the stronger. And that is why, dear Thrasymachus, I was saying just now that no one is prepared to

exercise rule, and get involved in correcting the evil ways of others, of his own free will. Instead ^{347a} he asks for a reward, because whoever is to enact anything properly by means of a skill never enacts what is best for himself, nor commands it either, when his commands are based upon the skill. Rather, he enacts what's best for whoever is ruled. These are the reasons, it seems, why there needs to be a reward for those who are going to consent to exercise rule, either money, honour, or a penalty if they will not exercise rule." "What do you mean by this, Socrates?" said Glaucon. "The first two rewards I recognise, but I do not understand what penalty you are referring to, or how you include it among the rewards."

^{347b}

"Then," said I, "you do not understand the reward of the best people, on account of which the most suitable people exercise rule, whenever they are willing to do so. Or do you not know that having a thirst for honour or for money is said to be, and is indeed, a reproach?" "I do," said he. "Well," said I, "that is why the good people are not willing to rule, either for the sake of money or honour. For they do not wish to be called hirelings for openly securing a reward from exercising authority, nor to be called thieves for profiting from their position of authority by stealth. Then again, they won't do it for the sake of honour either for they are not thirsty for honour. So in their ^{347c} case, there also needs to be some necessity or a penalty if they are going to want to exercise rule. And that is surely why it is regarded as a disgrace to seek to exercise rule of one's own free will and not wait for necessity. But if one is not willing to exercise rule oneself, the greatest penalty is to be ruled over by someone of lesser rate. And for fear of this penalty, it appears to me, the reasonable people exercise rule, whenever they do so. And then they set about exercising their authority, not as though they are embarking upon something good, nor as though they are going to do ^{347d} well out of it, but as a necessity,

because they are not able to entrust it to anyone better than or like themselves. “It is quite likely then that if there were a city constituted entirely of good men, there would be as much contention over not ruling as there is over exercising rule nowadays. And in that case it would become quite evident that, in fact, the true ruler does not, by nature, consider his own advantage, but the advantage of whoever is ruled. Accordingly, everyone who realises this would choose to be benefited by someone else rather than have the trouble of benefiting someone else.

347e

“So I do not agree with Thrasymachus at all, that what is just is the advantage of the stronger. Now, we shall consider this again on another occasion, but what Thrasymachus is now saying seems much more significant to me, when he maintains that the life of the unjust person is superior to the life of the just. Well, Glaucon,” said I, “which do you choose, and which formulation seems truer to you?” “Well, I say the life of the just person is more profitable.”

348a

“And did you hear how much good Thrasymachus ascribed a moment ago to the life of the unjust?” “I heard,” said he, “but I am not convinced.” “So do you want us to persuade him that he is not speaking the truth, if we can somehow find a way to do so?” “How could I not want that?” said he. “Well, if we argue against him, setting one speech against another, as to how much good there is in turn in being just, and he makes a reply, and we make another speech, it will be necessary to count up the good points and measure how many of them each of us made. And at that stage we shall need some judges to decide on the issue. But if we consider the matter as we did just now, 348b by coming to agreement with one another, we ourselves shall be both judges and pleaders at the same time.” “Yes, certainly,” said he. “So which approach do you like best?” I asked. “This

one,” Glaucon replied. “Come on then, Thrasymachus,” said I, “answer us, from the beginning. Do you maintain that complete injustice is more profitable than justice, when it too is complete?” “I certainly do maintain this,” said he, “and I have explained the reasons why.” “Well then, tell me what you say about them in this respect. I presume you refer to one of them as an excellence and the other as a vice?” “Of course.”

348c

“Justice being an excellence, and injustice a vice?” “Well, that is likely, my sweet friend, since I also say that injustice is profitable, while justice is not.” “What are you saying then?” “The opposite,” said he. “That justice is a vice?” “No, it is a very noble simple-mindedness.” “In that case, is injustice an evil disposition?” “No, it is sound judgement,” he said. “And do the unjust people also seem to you, Thrasymachus, to be intelligent and good?” “Yes, those who are able to be completely unjust at any rate,” said he, “and have the ability to bring cities and entire races of humans under their power. But perhaps you think I am ^{348d} speaking of pickpockets,” said he, “although this sort of thing is profitable too, as long as it goes undetected. Yet it is not worth mentioning compared to what I have just been speaking of.” “I am not unaware,” said I, “of the point you wish to make, but what surprised me was this: you placed injustice alongside excellence and wisdom, although you placed justice with their opposites.” “That is where I place them, very much so.”

348e

“This is now a tougher challenge, my friend, and it is no longer easy to come up with a response. For if you had proposed that injustice is profitable, and yet accepted that it is an evil and a disgrace, as some others do, we would have something to say by discussing it in conventional terms. But you are obviously going to say that it is noble and strong, and you will attribute to it all the other qualities that we used to attribute to justice since you

have even dared to place it alongside excellence and wisdom.”

349a

“Your prophecy could not be truer,” said he. “And yet,” said I, “I should not hold back from developing the argument, as long as I understand you to be saying what you are actually thinking. Indeed, Thrasymachus, I do not think you are joking at the moment. No, you are expressing your opinions as to what is true.” “What difference does it make to you,” said he, “whether this is my opinion or not? Why do you not just refute the argument?”

349b

“No reason,” said I. “But apart from all this, please try to answer one further question. Do you think the just person would want to get more than another just person, in any respect?” “Not at all,” said he. “Otherwise he would not be the charming, simple-minded fellow he actually is.” “And what of the just action?” “No, not that either,” he said. “And would he think he deserves to get more than the unjust person, and would he believe that this is just or would he not believe so?” “He would believe it,” said he, “and he would think he deserved it, but he would be unable to achieve it.”

349c

“But I am not asking you that,” said I, “but whether the just man wants, and thinks he deserves, to get more than the unjust man, but not more than the just man.” “Yes, that is it,” said he. “And what about the unjust man? Does he think he deserves to get more than the just man and more than the just action?” “How could he do otherwise,” he said, “when he thinks he deserves to get more than everyone?” “Will not the unjust also get more than the unjust person and the unjust action, and will he not strive, in all things, to get more for himself?” “That is it.”

349d

“Should we, in fact, put it like this?” I asked. “The just man does not get more than someone like himself, only someone unlike,

while the unjust gets more than his like and his unlike.” “An excellent formulation,” he said. “And yet the unjust person is intelligent and good,” said I, “while the just person is neither?” “That too is a good way of putting it,” said he. “In that case,” said I, “does not the unjust man resemble the intelligent and the good, while the just man does not?” “Yes, indeed,” said he. “How could this sort of person fail to resemble people like this, and how could the other fellow resemble them?” “Well said. So each of them is this sort of person. They are each the sort of people they resemble.” “What else could they be?” he said.

349e

“Very well, Thrasymachus. And do you say that one person is musical and another is unmusical?” “I do.” “Which of them is intelligent and which is unintelligent?” “The musical person is presumably intelligent, and the unmusical person unintelligent.” “Is he not good in matters wherein he is intelligent, and bad in matters wherein he is unintelligent?” “Yes.” “What about the medical man? Is not the situation the same?” “It is.” “So, best of men, would it seem to you that any musical man, when tuning his lyre, would want to get more than another musical man in tightening and loosening the strings, or would you think he deserves to get more?”

350a

“No, I do not think so.” “Would he want to get more than the unmusical man?” “Necessarily,” he replied. “And what about the medical man? In prescribing food and drink, do you think he would want to get more than the medical man, or the medical procedure?” “Of course not.” “But more than someone who is not a medical man?” “Yes.” “Well then, in the case of all knowledge and ignorance, consider this. Would anyone at all who is knowledgeable want to choose to do, or say, more than another knowledgeable person, rather than choosing the same as someone who is like himself, in the case of the same activity?” “Yes,” said he. “Perhaps that is how matters must

stand in this case.”

350b

“What about someone who is not knowledgeable? Would he not want to get more than both the knowledgeable person and the person who is not knowledgeable, in like manner?” “Probably.” “And whoever is knowledgeable is wise?” “I agree.” “And whoever is wise is good?” “I agree.” “So, whoever is good and wise does not want to get more than his like, although he does want to get more than his unlike, and his opposite.” “So it seems,” said he. “But whoever is bad and ignorant wants to get more than his like, and more than his opposite too.” “Apparently.”

350c

“In that case, Thrasymachus, does not our unjust man get more than his like and his unlike? Were you not saying this?” “I was,” said he. “And yet, whoever is just will not get more than his like, but he will get more than his unlike?” “Yes.” “So the just person,” said I, “resembles the wise and the good, while the unjust resembles the bad and the ignorant.” “Quite likely.” “But surely we agreed that whoever someone is like, that is the sort of person he actually is.” “We agreed indeed.” “So the just person has turned out, for us, to be good and wise, and the unjust person ignorant and bad.”

350d

Now, Thrasymachus did agree with all this, but not as easily as I am now describing. Rather he was dragged reluctantly, perspiring prodigiously as you would expect on a summer’s day. Then I saw what I had never seen before, Thrasymachus blushing. And since we had finally agreed that justice is excellence and wisdom, while injustice is badness and ignorance, I said, “There it is, let that be our position on this. And yet we also maintained that injustice is strong, or do you not remember, Thrasymachus?”

350e

"I remember," said he, "but what you are now saying is unsatisfactory to me, and I have something to say about this. Yet if I were to say it, I know quite well that you'd accuse me of making public speeches. So, either allow me to speak as much as I want to, or if you want to ask questions ask, and I shall respond with 'there it is', as we do to old women telling stories, and nod my head and shake my head." "No, no," said I, "not if it is contrary to your own opinion." "Yes, to satisfy you," he said. "Since you will not allow me to speak, what else do you want me to do?" "Nothing, by Zeus," said I. "But if you really are going to do this, do it, and I shall ask my questions." "Ask them."

351a

"Then I ask this question, the one I asked earlier, so that we may consider the argument thoroughly, in due order. What sort of thing is justice in relation to injustice? For it was said, somehow, that injustice is more powerful and stronger than justice, and yet now, if justice is indeed wisdom and excellence," said I, "I think it will easily be shown to be stronger than injustice, since, in fact, injustice is ignorance. No one could still fail to recognise that. But I have no desire, Thrasymachus, ^{351b} to consider this in such a facile manner, but somewhat as follows. Would you maintain that a city is unjust when it attempts to enslave other cities and reduce them to slavery, and indeed hold many more in subjection, having enslaved them already?" "Yes, of course. And the best city, being utterly unjust, will do this to the greatest extent." "I understand," said I, "that this was your argument, but I am considering the following question: whether a city that becomes stronger than another city will have this power, in the absence of justice, or is it necessary for it that justice be present?"

351c

"Well, if it is as you were just saying, and justice is wisdom, then this will happen when justice is present. But if it is as I was saying, then this will happen when injustice is present."

“Thrasymachus, I am really delighted,” said I, “that you are not only nodding and shaking your head, but also responding so beautifully.” “Yes,” said he, “I am being obliging towards you.” “It is nice of you to do so, but please oblige me a little more and tell me this. Do you think a city or an army, robbers or thieves, or any other group that jointly undertakes something in an unjust manner, would be able to accomplish anything if they were unjust towards one another?” “Of course not,” said he.

351d

“But what if they were not unjust to one another? Wouldn’t they be more likely to accomplish something?” “Very much so.” “Because injustice, Thrasymachus, presumably causes factions, hatred, and conflict among them, while justice brings like-mindedness and friendship. Is this so?” “Let it be so,” said he, “so that I do not have to differ with you.” “Again, that is good of you, best of men. But tell me this. If the function of injustice is to produce hatred wherever it is present, will it not also, whether it arises among free men or slaves, make them hate one another and develop factions, and be unable to act with one another jointly?”

351e

“Entirely so.” “And what if it arises among two people? Will they not differ, develop hatred, and become enemies of each other and of the just people?” “They will,” said he. “And if injustice arises in a single person, my surprising friend, will it lose its own power or will it still retain it nonetheless?” “Let us say it retains it nonetheless.”

352a

“Is it not apparent that the sort of power it has is as follows. Wherever it arises, be it in a city, a family, an army, or anything else at all, injustice first renders it incapable of acting in collaboration with itself because of faction and difference, and what’s more it makes it an enemy of itself, and of everything that is opposite to it, and of the just? Is this not the case?”

“Entirely so.”

352b

“And if it is present even in a single person, it will I presume produce those same outcomes, the outcomes it naturally produces. Firstly, injustice will render him incapable of action because he has inner factions and is not like-minded with himself, and also make him an enemy of himself, and of the just. Is this so?” “Yes.” “And surely, my friend, the gods too are just?” “So be it,” said he. “And in that case the unjust man will be an enemy of the gods, Thrasymachus, and the just man a friend.” “Feast away on your argument,” said he. “Have no fear. I shall not oppose you in case I incur the displeasure of these people here.”

352c

“Come on, then,” said I, “and complete what is left of the banquet for me by answering questions as you have just been doing. For the just are apparently wiser, better and more capable of action, while the unjust are not able to do anything together. And in fact, when we say that despite being unjust, people have on occasion accomplished something by working together jointly, with strength, we are not speaking the entire truth. For had they been perfectly unjust, they could not have restrained their injustice towards one another, so it is clear that some justice was present in them which prevented them from being unjust both to one another and the people they were set against at the same time. Because of this justice, they accomplished what they accomplished, and they embarked upon their unjust exploits only half-corrupted by injustice, since total degenerates, who are completely unjust, are also completely incapable of accomplishing anything.

352d

“Now, as I understand it, this is how matters stand, and not as you proposed at first. However, we should also consider the issue we put forward for consideration after that, whether the

just people live better lives than the unjust and are happier. Well, based on what we have said, in my opinion it now appears that they are happier. Nevertheless, we should consider this more thoroughly, for this argument is not concerned with any random issue. It concerns the manner in which our lives should be lived. "Consider it then," said he. "Very well," said I. "So tell me, do you think a horse has some function?" "I do." "And would you propose that this function of a horse, or of anything else, would be what can only be carried out with that, or is best carried out with that?" "I do not understand," said he.

352e

"Well, what about this? Can you see with anything else except your eyes?" "Of course not." "And again, can you hear with anything except your ears?" "Not at all." "Would we not be right to say that these are the functions of those organs?" "Entirely so." "What about this? Could you take a cutting from a vine with a dagger, a chisel, or with many other tools?" "Of course." "But you could not do it, I think, with anything else as well as you could do it with a pruning hook, manufactured for this purpose." "True." "In that case, should we not propose that this is its function?" "We should indeed."

353a

"Well, I think you should now have a better understanding of my line of questioning just now, when I was asking if the function of something is what it alone can accomplish or what it can accomplish better than anything else." "Yes," said he, "I now understand, and it seems to me that this is the function of anything."

353b

"Very well," said I. "Now, do you also think there is an excellence belonging to anything to which some function has been assigned? But let us go back again to the same examples. Is there some function of eyes, according to us?" "There is." "And in that case, is there also an excellence of eyes?" "An excellence

too.” “What about ears? Do they have a function?” “Yes.” “Have they not an excellence too?” “An excellence too.” “And in all other cases, does not the same apply?” “It does.”

353c

“Hold on. Could the eyes ever perform their own function properly without possessing their own particular excellence, but possessing a defect instead of the excellence?” “Well, how could they?” he replied. “For presumably you mean that they possess blindness instead of sight.” “I am not yet asking what their excellence might be, but whether anything that exercises a function carries out its own function well by means of its own excellence, and badly by means of its defect.” “Well, what you are saying is true in this case,” said he. “Will not the ears carry out their own function badly when deprived of their own excellence?” “Entirely so.”

353d

“So, do we apply the same argument to all the other instances?” “Well, I think so.” “Come on then, next consider the following. Is there some function of the soul that you could not perform by means of anything else there is, for instance, caring, ruling and deliberating, and everything of that sort? Is there anything else besides soul to which we might properly attribute these? Could we maintain that they are not particular to soul?” “They are particular to nothing else.” “And again, what about living? Shall we say that it is a function of soul?” “More than anything,” said he. “Do we not also say that there is some excellence of a soul?” “We say so.”

353e

“In that case, will a soul ever carry out its own functions well, Thrasymachus, when deprived of its own particular excellence, or is that impossible?” “It is impossible.” “So, of necessity, a bad soul exercises rule and care badly, and a good soul does all this well.” “Of necessity.” “Did we not agree that excellence of soul is justice, and badness is injustice?” “Yes, we agreed.” “Then,

the just soul, and the just man, will live well, while the unjust man will live badly.” “So it appears,” said he, “according to your argument.”

354a

“But someone who lives well is blessed and happy, while someone who does not is the opposite.” “Of course.” “In that case, the just person is happy, while the unjust is wretched.” “Let it be so,” said he. “But there is no profit in being wretched, but in being happy there is.” “Of course.” “Then, blessed Thrasymachus, injustice is never more profitable than justice.” “Well, Socrates, let this be your feast for the festival of Bendis.”

354b

“A feast provided by you, Thrasymachus,” said I, “once you became gentle with me and stopped being difficult. However, I have not feasted properly, but that’s my own fault, not yours. Rather, I think I am behaving like gluttons, who snatch at whatever is spread before them to get a taste before they have enjoyed the previous dish in due measure. Before considering the first thing we were looking for, the just, and what precisely it is, I let that go and set about considering something about this, whether it is badness and ignorance, or wisdom and excellence. And again later on, when another argument came my way, that injustice is more profitable than justice, I could not ^{354c} restrain myself from going after that and abandoning the other one. So the outcome of the discussion for me, at the moment, is that I know nothing. Since I do not know what precisely the just is, I shall hardly know whether it happens to be an excellence or not, or whether someone who possesses it is unhappy or happy.”

BOOK II

357a

Now, having said all this, I thought I was quit of the argument, but it turned out in the end to be a mere prelude. For Glaucon, who is always extremely forthright on every issue, on this occasion in particular could not accept the withdrawal of Thrasymachus, so he said, “Socrates, do you wish to seem to have persuaded us, or do you wish to persuade us truly that it is better in every way to be ^{357b} just rather than unjust?” “To persuade you truly,” said I. “That is what I would choose if it were up to me.” “Well, then,” said he, “you are not doing what you wish to do. Yes, tell me this. Do you think there is a kind of good that we would choose to have not with a view to getting something out of it, but because we welcome it for its own sake, like enjoyment and pleasures that are harmless and produce no future consequences apart from enjoying their possession?” “Well,” said I, “I think there is a good of this kind.”

^{357c}

“What about the kind we prize both for its own sake and for what it gives rise to, thinking, for instance, and seeing, or being healthy, since we welcome these, presumably, for both reasons?” “Yes,” said I. “And do you see a third form of good which includes physical exercise, being healed when you are ill, healing others, and money-making in general? These we would say are troublesome, and although they benefit us we would not choose to have them for their own sake but for their rewards and for whatever else they give rise to.”

^{357d}

“Yes, indeed,” said I. “There is also this third form, but what about it?” “In which of these three do you place justice?” he asked.

^{358a}

“I think,” said I, “that it belongs in the noblest of the three, the one that should be prized for itself and for what it gives rise to by anyone who is to be blessed.” “Well, most people do not think so,” said he. “They think it belongs in the troublesome

form that should be practised for the sake of its rewards, and for reputation based on appearance, but just by itself it should be avoided because it is difficult.” “I know that that is how they think,” said I, “and Thrasymachus has been criticising justice for some time for being like this, and he has been praising injustice. But it seems I am a slow learner.”

358b

“Come on, then,” said he, “and see if you still hold the same view after you listen to me. For Thrasymachus seems to me like a snake who has submitted to your charms more meekly than he should, since to my mind no proof on either side has yet been given. For I am eager to hear what each is, and what power each possesses, just by itself, when present in the soul, and to set to one side their rewards and whatever arises from them.

358c

“So I shall proceed in this way if, indeed, it seems acceptable to you. I shall revive Thrasymachus’ argument, and I shall say first the sort of thing they maintain justice is, and where it has come from. Secondly, I shall show that everyone who practises it does so against their own ^{358d} free will, as a necessity and not as something good. And thirdly, I shall demonstrate that they are acting reasonably in doing so, because the life of the unjust is actually far better than the life of the just, according to them. “Although this is not how it seems to me at all, Socrates, I am perplexed, nevertheless, from hearing Thrasymachus and countless others assailing my ears, while the argument on behalf of justice, that it is better than injustice, I have heard so far from no one in the way I wish to hear it. I wish to hear justice itself being praised for itself, and I think I am most likely to get this from you.

358e

“That is why I shall speak forcibly in praise of the unjust life, and in speaking like this I shall demonstrate to you the manner in which I want to hear you, in turn, censuring injustice and

praising justice. So let us see if what I am proposing is to your liking.” “More than anything,” said I. “Yes, what could be more delightful to a person of intelligence than hearing about this issue and discussing it again and again?”

359a

“You put that perfectly,” said he. “Now, listen to the first thing I said I was going to say on this matter, the sort of thing justice is, and where it has come from. Indeed, according to them, doing injustice is good by nature, while suffering injustice is bad, and the badness in suffering injustice far exceeds the good in doing it. And so, when people are being unjust to one another, and suffering injustice too, and getting a taste of both the doing and the suffering, those who are unable to avoid the one and opt for the other think it profitable to enter a contract with one another, neither to do injustice nor to suffer it. From there they began to set down laws, mutual contracts, and to call whatever the law commands lawful and just. This they say is the origin and the very ^{359b} essence of justice. It is a middle ground between what is best – not paying a penalty when you act unjustly – and what is worst – being unable to get revenge when you suffer injustice. And what is just, being midway between both extremes, is prized not as something good but as something that is respected due to an inability to do injustice, since a true man, who can actually do this, would never enter into a contract with anyone neither to do injustice nor to suffer injustice. That would be madness. So, Socrates, according to their argument, such is the nature of justice. This is what it is like, and such are its natural origins.

359c

“Now, we would be most likely to see that those who practise justice do so against their will because they lack the power to act unjustly, if we were to picture in mind a situation somewhat as follows. Let us grant each of these two, the just and the unjust person, licence to do whatever they want. Then we shall

accompany them and watch where their desire may lead them in each case. We would then catch the just person, in the very act, doing the same thing as the unjust person, getting more. This is what every nature naturally pursues as something good, despite being forcibly misled by law into respecting equality.

359d

“The sort of licence I am referring to would be most apparent if they were to possess the power that they say once belonged to the ancestor of Gyges of Lydia.¹⁸ Well, he was a shepherd working for the then ruler of Lydia, when there was a huge storm and an earthquake. The ground broke apart and a chasm appeared in the very place he was tending the flocks. When he saw it he was amazed, went down into it and, the story goes, he beheld other amazing sights, including a hollow bronze horse which had little doors. And when he bent down and peeped in, he saw that there was a corpse inside that appeared to be larger than a human. This corpse was wearing nothing else apart from a gold ring on its finger. He removed the ring and went out again.

359e

“When the usual meeting of shepherds was held to report to the king, on a monthly basis, on the state of his flocks, he arrived wearing the ring. As he sat down with the others, he happened to turn the ring around towards himself to the inside of his hand. With that, he became invisible to the people he was sitting with, and they spoke about him as if he was not there. He was amazed, and as he fiddled with the ring again he turned the ring outwards, and he immediately became visible once more. Once he had noticed this, he tested the ring out to see if it really had this power, ^{360a} and he found that this was so. On turning the ring inwards he became invisible, on turning it outwards he became visible.

360b

“Having become aware of this, he immediately contrived to become one of the messengers that go to the king. When he got there he seduced the king’s wife, and with her assistance he set upon the king, killed him, and took over the kingship.

360c

“Now, if there were two rings like this, and one was worn by our just person, the other by our unjust person, there is no one, it would seem, with such adamant resolve as to abide by justice, and dare to refrain from touching other people’s possessions when it is possible for him, with no fear, to take whatever he wants from the market, go into private houses and lie with whomever he wants, to kill anyone, or free anyone he wants from prison, and to behave generally among his fellow men as though he were the equal of a god. But behaving in this manner he would not be doing anything different from the other fellow. They would both be going down the same path.

360d

“So, someone might say that this is strong evidence that no one, of his own free will, is just, but only when he is compelled to be so, because being just is not something that is good for him personally, since whenever a person believes he will be able to act unjustly, he will do so. For every man believes that injustice is far more profitable, personally, than justice. And what they believe is true, as anyone who puts forward an argument of this sort will maintain, because if someone who has obtained such licence as this never had any desire to act unjustly, nor to lay hands on other people’s possessions, he would be regarded as wretched and devoid of intelligence by those who noticed, although they would still praise him when face to face with one another, deceiving one another completely because of their fear of suffering injustice.

360e

“Well then, so much for that. As for this decision concerning the life of the people we are speaking of, we shall be able to decide

the issue correctly once we contrast the most just person with the most unjust, but not otherwise. So what contrast do I mean? It is as follows. Let us take nothing away from the injustice of the unjust man, nor from the justice of the just man. No, let us propose that each of them is perfect in terms of his own conduct. So in the first place, let the unjust man act like expert craftsmen, such as a foremost steersman or physician, who is fully aware of ^{361a} the impossibilities and the possibilities associated with his skill, and who attempts what is possible and sets aside what is impossible. And even if he slips up somewhere, he is up to the task of setting it right. So we should also allow the unjust man, attempting his unjust acts in the correct manner, to go undetected if he is going to be utterly unjust. And we should regard the fellow who gets caught as inept, for the pinnacle of injustice is to seem just, even though one is not.

^{361b}

“So, let us grant complete injustice to the completely unjust person, and there should be no omissions, but we should allow him, whilst perpetrating the greatest injustices, to have provided himself with the greatest reputation for justice. And even if he does slip up somewhere, let us grant him the ability to set it right, to speak persuasively enough if any of his unjust actions are ever exposed, and to use force to whatever extent force is needed, because he has the courage and strength to do so and because he is well supplied with friends and property. And having put an unjust person of this sort in place, we should set the just person alongside him, in our account, a simple, noble man who, as Aeschylus says, wishes to be good, and not just to seem so.¹⁹

^{361c}

“So we must take away this ‘seeming’, for if he is going to seem just, he will have honours and privileges because he seems to be this sort of person. Accordingly, it will not be clear whether he

is the sort of person he is for the sake of justice or for the sake of the privileges and honours.

361d

So we should strip away everything else apart from justice, and make his situation the exact opposite of the previous fellow. For although he is doing nothing unjust, let him have an enormous reputation for injustice so that he may be well tested, in terms of justice, by resisting any softening in the face of a bad reputation, and whatever results from that. But let him persist unto death, undeflected in his course, reputed to be unjust even though he is just, so that both men, having attained the pinnacle of justice in one case and of injustice in the other, may be judged as to which of the two is happier.”

361e

“My, my, dear Glaucon,” said I, “how thoroughly you clean up both men for judgement, as though they were two statues.” “I am doing my best,” said he, “and since they are both like this, it will no longer be hard, in my view, to complete our account of the sort of life that is in store for each of them. So this should be described, Socrates, and in this case, if it is described in very crude terms, do not presume that I am the one who is saying this. No, it is the people who praise injustice above justice.

362a

“The people will say that the just man in this situation will be whipped, stretched on the rack, put in chains, have his eyes burned out, and finally, having suffered all possible evils, he will be impaled and will come to realise that one should not wish to be just, but to seem to be so. And the saying of Aeschylus turns out to be much more applicable to the unjust man. For they maintain that, in fact, the unjust man, since he is engaging in something that adheres to truth and does not live his life according to mere seeming, does not wish to seem unjust but to be so, *Enjoying the fruits of the deep furrow of thought / From which sagacious counsel is sprung.*

362b

“Firstly, he rules in the city because he seems to be just. Then he marries a wife from any family he wants and gives his children in marriage to whomsoever he wants, does business with anyone he wishes, and as well as being benefited by all of this he also gains by having no scruples about doing injustice. So, in competitive situations in private or in public, they say he wins out and gets more than his enemies, and is wealthy because he gets more, and so he does good to his friends ^{362c} and harm to his enemies. And he makes sufficient sacrifices and offerings to the gods, magnificently, and serves the gods and any people he wants to far better than the just man. As a result, they say it is more appropriate, in all probability, that he be more beloved of the gods than the just man. On this basis, Socrates, they say that from the gods, and from his fellow man too, the life provided to the unjust person is better than what is provided to the just.”

362d

When Glaucon had said all this, I had in mind to say something in response, but his brother, Adimantus, said, “You surely do not imagine, Socrates, that enough has now been said about this argument?” “But why not?” said I. “The very point,” said he, “that most needed to be made has not been made.”

362e

“In that case,” said I, “as the saying goes, ‘Let a brother be there for a brother’,²⁰ and so you should come to his aid if this man has left anything out. And yet, for my part, what he has said already is enough to floor me and render me incapable of coming to the assistance of justice.” “You are talking nonsense,” said he. “And yet, you should also listen to this. Yes, it is necessary that we go through the opposite arguments to the ones he recounted, arguments that praise justice and censure injustice so that the point I think Glaucon wishes to make may be clarified.

363a

“Fathers, when speaking to their sons and offering them advice, and indeed anyone who cares for anyone, speak to them presumably about the need to be just by praising not justice itself but the good reputation derived from it, saying that by seeming to be just, from the reputation alone, they may secure positions of authority, and marriages, and whatever else Glaucon listed just now, all from having a reputation for being just.

363b

“Yet these people have more to say on the subject of reputation. For when they throw in good reputation in the eyes of the gods, they describe a whole host of goods that they declare are given by the gods to holy people, just as noble Hesiod, and Homer too, declare in one case that for the just people the gods make oak trees *Bear acorns in their topmost branches with swarms of bees below* “And he says, *Their woolly sheep are weighed down with fleeces.*²¹ And there are many other good things connected to these. In the other case, Homer says something similar: 363c *as of some king who, as a blameless man and god-fearing / and ruling as lord over many powerful people, / upholds the way of good government, and the black earth yields him / barley and wheat, his trees are heavy with fruit, his sheep flocks / continue to bear young, the sea gives him fish.*²² “But the goods from the gods that Musaeus and his son bestow upon the just people are more novel than these.²³ In their account they lead them into Hades, and having set them reclining at a symposium of holy people which they have prepared, they crown them with garlands and make them 363d spend their time thereafter in a drunken state in the belief that the supreme reward for excellence is eternal drunkenness. Others extend the rewards from the gods even further than this, for they maintain that holy people who are faithful to their oaths leave behind them a whole race, children and children’s children.

363e

“So, in these respects, and in others like these, they sing the praises of justice while they sink the unholy and unjust people into some mire in Hades and compel them to carry water in a sieve. And while they are still alive they bring them into evil repute, and they ascribe to these unjust people all the punishments that Glaucon listed for those who are just, but have a reputation for being unjust. But they have nothing else to say.

364a

“Such then is the praise and the censure associated with each, with the just and the unjust. But as well as these, Socrates, consider also the kind of arguments about justice and injustice spoken by ordinary folk and by the poets. For they all, with one voice, keep saying that justice and sound-mindedness are something glorious but difficult and hard work to attain, while lack of restraint and injustice are pleasant and easy to attain, and only by opinion and convention are they a disgrace.

364b

“They say that unjust actions are, for the most part, more profitable than just ones, and they regard bad people who are wealthy and generally powerful as happy, and they have no scruples about honouring them in public and in private while disrespecting and looking down on those who are in some way weak or poor, even whilst agreeing that these are better people than the others.

364c

“But the most surprising of all these things is what they say about the gods and about excellence. They say that the gods themselves allot misfortunes and a bad life to many good people, and an opposite fate to people of the opposite sort. And begging priests and soothsayers, going to the doors of the wealthy man, convince him that they have a power provided by the gods through sacrifices and incantations to make good any injustice committed by him or his ancestors with pleasant

festivities. And if he wants to bring ruin upon some enemy, with minimal expenditure on ^{364d} his part, he may do harm to just and unjust alike with certain incantations and spells which, they claim, persuade the gods to serve them. And they bring forth poets as supporting witnesses to all these arguments, some making the case that badness is easy because *Badness is abundant and easy to lay hold of. / The road is smooth and it dwells very close at hand. / But the gods have placed sweat in front of the path of excellence* “and a road that is long and rough and steep.”²⁴ Others bring in Homer as their witness that the gods are turned by humans, because he too said, *Even the gods themselves are moved by prayer. / By sacrifices and soothing vows, / Libations and burnt offerings, / Humanity turns the will of the gods; / Praying whenever someone has transgressed or gone astray.*²⁵

^{364e}

“And they produce a confused array of books by Musaeus and Orpheus, the offspring of Selene²⁶ and of the Muses they say, on the basis of which they perform their sacrificial rites, convincing not only private citizens but whole cities that there are remissions and purifications of their unjust deeds available through sacrifices and playful pleasantries to those who are still alive and also to those who have died. These they call initiations, which deliver us from the evils of the other world, where horrors await those who have not performed the sacrifices.

^{365a}

“Dear Socrates,” said he, “when all this is being said about excellence and badness, and the esteem in which they are held by gods and by humans, and when it is said so often in these various ways, what do we think this will do to the souls of the young when they hear it, young people who are gifted and up to the task of, as it were, flitting between all the various formulations and working out from them the sort of person one should be, and how one should behave in order to lead the very

best life possible? Indeed, he would be most likely to ask himself, after the manner of Pindar: *Shall I, by justice or by crooked deceit / Ascend the high wall and, thus fortified, / live out the rest of my life?*

365b

“For according to what is being said, there is no advantage to me in being just if I actually seem unjust, only trouble and losses that are plain to be seen. But if I am unjust and have secured a reputation for justice, a divinely sweet life is promised. Therefore, since the wise explain to me that seeming overpowers the truth and is lord of happiness, to this indeed should I turn fully. I must sketch about myself a shadowy picture of excellence as an exterior façade whilst trailing the cunning, subtle fox of the all-wise Archilochus behind me.”²⁷

365c

“‘But surely,’ someone will declare, ‘it is not easy to be bad and go undetected always.’ ‘Indeed,’ we shall say, ‘nothing else that is worthwhile is an easy matter either. Nevertheless, if we are going to enjoy happiness, this is the path we must follow since that is the way the footprints of these arguments are leading us. So we shall form companies and associations in order to avoid being detected, and there are teachers of persuasion who, for a fee, impart the wisdom needed for public speaking and for winning lawsuits. Based on these, we shall use persuasion in some cases, and force in other cases, so that we may continue to get more, with impunity.’

365d

“‘But, of course,’ someone might say, ‘you do not go undetected by the gods, nor can you use force against them.’ ‘But what if there are no gods, or human affairs do not concern them at all? Why should we, for our part, care about not being detected? If, on the other hand, there are gods and they do care about us, we know about them and have heard of them from no other sources than the laws and the genealogies of the poets, the very

sources who are saying they are amenable to being turned and persuaded by sacrifices, soothing vows and offerings. We must believe either ^{365e} both or neither. Now, if they are to be believed, then we should act unjustly and offer sacrifice from the fruits of our unjust acts. For by being just we shall merely go unpunished by the gods, but we shall forgo the advantages born of injustice. However, by being unjust we shall have the advantages, and by praying when we transgress or fall into error we shall win them over and escape unpunished.'

^{366a}

"'But surely,' someone may say, 'we shall pay a just penalty in Hades for whatever injustices we may have done here, either ourselves or our children's children.' 'But, my friend,' he will reply on reflection, 'the initiations, for their part, are extremely powerful, and so are the gods of deliverance. So say the greatest cities and the children of the gods who have become ^{366b} the gods' poets and prophets, and who reveal that this is indeed the case.'

^{366c}

"Now, by what argument might we still choose justice in preference to gross injustice, which we may attain along with a fraudulent seemliness, and act as we are minded to act with gods and with humans, in life and after death, as the argument of most people, and of the special folk too, proclaims? Indeed, from all that has been said, is there any way, Socrates, that anyone possessed of any intellectual, physical, financial or family power would be willing to revere justice, and not laugh when he hears it being praised? And so, if someone is able to demonstrate that what we have said is false, and has recognised well enough that justice is best, he has a lot of sympathy with those who are unjust and is not angry with them. He knows, rather, that apart from someone who cannot bear to act unjustly because of a divine nature, or who refrains from it because of the knowledge he has acquired, no one else is just of

their own free will. Rather, they censure unjust action ^{366d} out of cowardice, old age, or some other weakness, because they are powerless to enact it. This must be obvious, because the first such person who attains the power to do so, is the first person to act unjustly as much as he possibly can.

^{366e}

“And there is no other cause of all this except the origin of this entire argument, directed by Glaucon and myself towards you, Socrates, to make the case that, ‘Come on, my wonderful man. Of all of you who claim to be champions of justice, beginning with the earliest heroes whose utterances are still with us, right down to human beings today, no one so far has censured injustice or praised justice on any other basis than reputation, esteem, and the advantages that derive from them. And no one so far, either in poetry or in ordinary language, has described in a sufficiently detailed argument what each does itself, by its own power, when present in the soul of its possessors, unnoticed by gods and humans, an argument according to which injustice is the worst of all ^{367a} the evils that any soul can have within itself, while justice is the greatest good. For if you had all described it in these terms from the beginning, and convinced us of this from our earliest years, we would not have been acting as one another’s guardians for fear we might behave unjustly, but each of us would himself be his own guardian for fear that by acting unjustly he would have to live with the worst evil of all.’

^{367b}

“This, Socrates, and perhaps even more than this, is what Thrasymachus, and anyone else too I suppose, might say about justice and injustice, by crudely misrepresenting, in my opinion at any rate, the power they possess. But I, and I need to hide nothing from you, am speaking as forcefully as I possibly can because I am eager to hear you expressing the opposite views. Do not just show us, by your argument, that justice is stronger

than injustice, but show what each of them, just by itself, is doing to their possessor, such that one is bad and the other good. And take away the reputations that go with them, as Glaucon directed you, for unless you take away the ^{367c} true reputations from each, and substitute the false ones, we shall say that you are not praising what is just, but what is reputed to be just, nor are you censuring what is unjust, but what is reputed to be so, and you are encouraging us to be unjust without being noticed. And you are agreeing with Thrasymachus that what is just is someone else's good since it is the advantage of the stronger, while what is unjust is to one's own advantage and it is profitable, but it is disadvantageous to the weaker.

^{367d}

“Now, since you have agreed that justice is among the greatest goods, those that are worth acquiring for the sake of all that comes from them, but much more so for themselves – goods like sight, hearing, intelligence, and indeed health, and whatever other goods are fruitful by their own nature, and not merely by opinion – you should therefore praise this particular aspect of justice which, in its own right, benefits its possessor, while injustice does him harm. Leave the rewards and the reputations for others to praise, because although I might put up with other people when they are praising justice and censuring injustice in this way, by extolling or bewailing their associated reputations and rewards, I will not accept it from you unless you order me to do so, because you have spent your whole life considering this issue and nothing else.

^{367e}

“So, do not just show us, by our argument alone, that justice is stronger than injustice, but show what each of them, just by itself, is doing to their possessor, whether gods or humans notice this or not, such that one is good and the other bad.”

^{368a}

Now, although I had always admired the natural qualities of Glaucon and Adimantus, nevertheless, when I heard them on this occasion I was utterly delighted and I said, “You are worthy sons of your own father, and that admirer of Glaucon’s began his eulogy of you quite nicely, after you had distinguished yourselves at the battle of Megara, when he said, *Sons of Ariston, a godlike race is born of an illustrious man.*

368b

“And I think this captures the point quite well, my friends, for you have been much influenced by the divine if you are able to speak of injustice in these terms, without being convinced that it is better than justice. And it does seem to me that you are, in truth, unconvinced. And my evidence for this is your character in general, since on the basis of your speeches themselves, I would have doubted you both. But the more I trust you, the more I am at a loss as to how I should proceed, for I am not able to render any assistance. Indeed, I seem to be incapable of doing so, as indicated by the fact that you have not accepted what I said to Thrasymachus, which I thought showed that justice is better than injustice. Nor again am I capable of not rendering assistance, for I am afraid that 368c it might be an unholy act were I to be present when justice is being ill-spoken of, and fail her by not coming to her aid while I still had life and power of utterance. So under the circumstances, it is best that I help her to the best of my ability.” Now, Glaucon, and the others too, begged me in all sorts of ways to render assistance and not give up on the argument, but to examine in detail what each is and where the truth really lies about the benefit of each. So, I said what I was thinking. “The enquiry we are undertaking is no ordinary one,” said I. “No, it calls for keen vision. That is how it seems to me. Now, since we are not clever people,” I said, “I think we should conduct an investigation somewhat as follows. It is as if someone 368d had ordered us to read very small letters from afar when we are not very keen-sighted, and someone

then realised that the same letters are situated somewhere else, but larger, and on something larger. I think it would look like a godsend to read the smaller letters after we have first read the larger ones, if they happened to be the same.” “Yes, indeed,” said Adimantus, “but what do you see of this sort of thing in our enquiry into justice, Socrates?” “I will tell you,” said I. “We maintain that there is justice of an individual man, and presumably also of an entire city?”

368e

“Certainly,” said he.

369a

“Is a city not larger than an individual man?” “Larger,” said he. “Then, surely there would be more justice in the larger, and it would be easier to apprehend. So, if you wish, first let us enquire into the sort of thing justice is in the cities. Then, on this basis, we may consider it even in one individual, thus considering the likeness of the larger in the character of the smaller.” “Yes, I think that is a good suggestion,” said he. “In that case,” said I, “if we were to watch a city coming into being in words, would we not also see the justice of the city coming into being, and its injustice too?” “Quite likely,” said he.

369b

“And once this had come into being, could we not hope to see what we are seeking more easily?” “Very much so.” “So do you think we should attempt to proceed with this, for I think this is no small task? So give it some consideration.” “It has been considered,” said Adimantus, “and it simply must be done.” “Well,” said I, “a city comes into being, as I see it, because none of us are actually self-sufficient. Indeed, we all fall short of this in many respects. Or do you think there is some other principle for the foundation of a city?” “Not at all,” he replied.

369c

“And so, it is that one person associates with another person for one purpose and with someone else for a different purpose, and

since we all have many needs, we assemble people together into a single dwelling place as associates and helpers, and to this shared abode we give the name 'city'. Is this so?" "It is so." "And does one person give to another, if he does so, or receive something on the assumption that he himself will be better off." "Very much so." "Come on, then," said I. "Let us make a city from the beginning, in words. And it seems that our own needs will be making it." "Of course."

369d

"And, indeed, the first and greatest of needs is for the provision of food, for the sake of being and living." "Entirely so." "The second is for housing, and the third is for clothing and such like." "That is it." "Come on," said I. "What size city will be sufficient to provide for as many needs as this? Will there not be one farmer, a house builder too, and someone else who is a weaver? Or should we also add a shoemaker to it, and someone else who looks after bodily needs?" "By all means." "In any case, the absolute minimum for a city to be a city would consist of four or five men." "So it appears."

369e

"What then? Should each one of them place his own work at the joint disposal of everyone else? Should the farmer, for instance, one man, provide food for the other four and spend four times the time and the effort in providing food which he shares with the others? Or should he pay them no attention and produce a quarter of the food for himself in a quarter of the time, spending the remaining three quarters in providing a house, clothing and some shoes, without having to bother about sharing with others, and attend to his own concerns just by himself?"

370a

And Adimantus replied, "The first way, Socrates, is probably easier than that." "That is nothing strange, by Zeus," said I. "Indeed, now that you say so, it also occurs to me that in the

first place people are, by nature, not much like one another, rather they are naturally different. So one person is suited to one task, another to another task. Do you not think so?" "I do."

370b

"What about this? Would someone, one person, fare better by practising a lot of skills, or is it better when one person practises one skill?" "When one practises one," said he. "Then again, I believe, it is also obvious that if we neglect the right moment for some task, it comes to naught." "Yes, that is obvious." "Indeed, in my view, that is because what is to be done is not prepared to wait until the person who is to do it has the time. No, the person needs to attend closely to what is to be done, not partially as a secondary task." "Yes, he must." "On this basis then, more is accomplished, and better and more easily, when one person does one thing that accords with his nature, at the right moment, free of involvement in anything else." "Entirely so."

370c

"Then, Adimantus, more than four citizens are needed to provide all the services we were speaking of. For the farmer, it seems, will not make his own plough himself if it is to be a good one, nor his mattock either, nor any of the other tools required for farming. This applies to the house builder too, who also needs a lot of tools, as does the weaver and shoemaker." "True." "So carpenters, blacksmiths, and many craftsmen of this sort, becoming partners of our little city, will make it quite populous." "Yes, certainly."

370d

"And it still would not be very large if we were to add oxherds and shepherds to their number, and other herdsmen, so that the farmers would have oxen for ploughing, and the house builders, and farmers too, would have beasts of burden to use for carrying loads, and the weavers and shoemakers would have leather and wool." "Indeed," said he, "it would not be a small

city either, if it contained all these.” “And what is more,” said I, “it will be well-nigh impossible to found the city itself in a place where there will be no need of imported goods.” “Impossible indeed.”

370e

“So there will be a further need for even more people, who will import whatever is needed from other cities.” “There will.” “And, indeed, if our agent goes empty handed, bringing nothing which the other cities need, goods they would import, goods they themselves need, he will return empty handed. Is this so?” “I think so.” “Then they need to produce at home not just enough for themselves, but also enough of the sort of goods that are needed by the cities they depend upon.” “Yes, they need to.” “So our city needs more farmers and other artificers.” “Yes, more.” “Then I presume we shall also need additional agents, who will import and export the goods in each case. These people are traders, are they not?”

371a

“Yes.” “Then we shall also need traders.” “Very much so.”

371b

“And if the trading is to take place by sea, then there will be a further need for a lot more people who are knowledgeable about seafaring.” “A lot more, indeed.” “And what happens in this city itself? How will each group share the products of their labour with one another? This was after all the very reason we founded our city and established a community.” “Obviously,” said he, “through buying and selling.” “Then a marketplace will arise from this, and a system of currency to facilitate the exchange.” “Yes, certainly.”

371c

“Now, if the farmer, or one of the other artificers brings something he has produced along to the marketplace and does not arrive at the same time as those who want to exchange what he has with him, will he sit about in the marketplace idle, not

occupied with his own work?" "Not at all," said he. "There are people who see this situation and take on this function themselves. In cities that are properly managed, they are in general the least able-bodied ^{371d} folk, unsuited to involvement in any other work. For they need to wait about in the marketplace and exchange money for goods with people who wish to sell something, and again, goods for money with those who wish to buy something." "So this particular need," said I, "is what gives rise to retailers in our city. Or do we not call those who set themselves up in the marketplace to act as agents for buying and selling, retailers, while referring to those who travel from city to city as traders?" "Yes, certainly."

^{371e}

"And there are still others too, I believe, agents who, when it comes to intellectual matters, are not really worthy of our community. And yet, they possess enough physical strength for manual labour. So they sell the use of their strength, referring to their reward as a wage, and that is why they are called wage-earners, I suppose. Is this so?" "Yes." "Then wage-earners also fill out the population of our city?" "I think so." "Well then, Adimantus, at this stage, has our city grown to full size?" "Perhaps." "So where exactly would justice and injustice be in this city, and did it arise at the same time as one of the groups we have been considering?"

^{372a}

"I have no idea, Socrates," said he, "unless perhaps it is in some need the groups themselves had for one another." "And perhaps you have a good point," said I, "and we really should investigate it and not hold back. So, let us first consider the manner of life of people who are provided for in this way. Will they not make bread, wine, clothing and shoes? And having built their houses, they will work for ^{372b} the most part naked and unshod in summer, and in winter they will be clothed and shod well enough. They will be fed on meal and flour from the

barley and wheat they are provided with, baking and kneading noble cakes and loaves, which they serve up on some reeds or clean leaves as they recline on rustic beds strewn with yew and myrtle; feasting themselves and their children, then drinking their wine, with garlands on their heads as they sing the praises of the gods; delighting ^{372c} in one another's company and not begetting children beyond their resources to support them, being wary of poverty and war." Then Glaucon interjected. "It seems," said he, "that you are making these men partake of a feast devoid of relish."

^{372d}

"What you say is true," said I. "I had forgotten that they will also have relish, salt of course, olives and cheese too, and they will boil up onions and greens as people in the countryside do. And we shall also provide them with desserts, I suppose, of figs, pulses and beans, and they will roast myrtle berries and acorns by the fire, sipping their wine in moderation. And so will they live out their lives, in peace and health, and when, as is likely, they die in old age, they will bequeath another such life to their descendants." "Well, Socrates," said he, "if you were providing for a city of pigs, what else would you feed the beasts with?" "But how should it be done, Glaucon?" I asked. "In the conventional manner," said he. "People who are not going to be in discomfort should, I believe, recline on couches, dine at tables, and have various relishes available to them, the very ones they have nowadays, and desserts too."

^{372e}

"Very well," said I, "I understand. It seems we are not just considering how a city comes into existence, but how a luxurious city does so. And perhaps that is not a bad development either, for by considering something like this, we may perhaps discern how exactly justice and injustice develop in a city. Now, I think the true city is the one we have been describing, a healthy one, in a sense. But if you still want to, let

us look at a city in a feverish state. There is no reason not to. In fact for some people, it seems, all this is not sufficient, nor is the lifestyle itself. They will add couches, tables and other furniture, relishes of course, perfumes, incense, courtesans and cakes, each in endless variety. And what is more, all that we first mentioned – housing, clothing and shoes – should no longer be designated as our necessities. No, we should also get painting underway, embroidery too, and we should acquire gold, ivory, and everything else like that. Is this so?” “Yes,” said he.

373a

“In that case, will our city not need to be made bigger again? Indeed, that healthy city is no longer sufficient. It already needs to be filled out in size, with lots of things that are no longer in cities for the sake of necessity, with hunters of all sorts, for instance, imitators too, many of them concerned with shapes and colours, many concerned with music; poets too and those who serve them as rhapsodes, actors, chorus members and contractors, and artificers of a whole variety of articles for general use, and indeed for female adornment. And so, we shall also require more of these agents. Or does it not seem that we shall need people who look after children, wet nurses, nurses, beauticians, barbers, and, moreover, people to make the relishes, and cooks? And we shall still need to include 373b swineherds, since there were none in our previous city because it didn’t need them. However, they will need to be included in this city. And it will also need a whole host of other beasts if they are to be eaten. Is this not so?” “Inevitably.” “Once we live in this way, will we not also have a requirement for far more doctors than were needed in the previous city?” “Far more.”

373c

“And presumably our territory, which was once sufficient to feed the population at the time, will then become too small and sufficient no longer. Is this the case?” “Just so,” said he. “In that case, we shall have to cut off a slice of our neighbour’s territory

if we are to have enough land to pasture and plough. They in turn will do the same to ours, if they too give themselves over to the unbridled acquisition of wealth, exceeding the limit of the necessities.” “That is quite inevitable, Socrates,” said he. “What follows this then, Glaucon, is that we shall wage war. Is this what will happen?” “Just so,” said he.

373d

“And,” said I, “we really should not say anything yet as to whether war accomplishes anything ^{373e} good, or anything bad either. Let us just say this much: that we have also discovered the origin of war. It originates where most of the cities’ public or private evils originate, whenever they arise.” “Yes, certainly.”

374a

“Then our city must be even larger, my friend, not a little larger, but larger by an entire army, that will go forth and fight against our adversaries, in defence of all that wealth and whatever else we referred to just now.” “Why is that?” said he. “Are the citizens themselves not up to the task?” “Not if you and the rest of us,” said I, “were right to agree, when we were fashioning our city, that it is impossible for one person to practise many skills well. I presume you remember.” “What you say is true,” said he.

374b

“Well now,” said I, “do you not think that warfare and combat is a skilled activity?” “Very much so,” said he. “So, does the skill of shoemaking deserve more care than that of warfare?” “Not at all.” “Well then, we prevented the shoemaker from attempting to be either a farmer, a weaver or a house builder at the same time, rather than just being a shoemaker, so that we would then have the job of shoemaking done properly. And we assigned one task to each one of the others in like manner, ^{374c} the one for which each was naturally suited, and which he was going to work at throughout his life, free from involvement in other

tasks, and not missing the appropriate moment for carrying out the task well. “So then, in the case of warfare, is it not of the utmost importance that this be carried out well? Or is it so easy that whilst engaged in farming, someone may be skilled in warfare at the same time and be practising shoemaking, or any other skill at all, although there is no one who could be sufficiently skilled, even at playing draughts or dice, who did not pursue this alone from ^{374d} childhood, rather than treating it as a pastime? And will someone who grabs a shield or some other piece of military equipment or weaponry be a competent combatant in warfare as a hoplite, or in some other form of combat, there and then? Grabbing any of the other tools will not make anyone a craftsman or an athlete, nor will they be of use to someone who has not got the knowledge in each case, and has not given it sufficient practice.” “If that were the case,” said he, “the tools would be of enormous value.”

^{374e}

“Then,” said I, “insofar as the work of the guardians is the most important work, should it not, to that extent, be unencumbered by any other duties, and, indeed, require the utmost skill and attention?” “Yes, I think so,” said he. “In that case, will it not also require a nature suited to the activity itself?” “Of course.” “Then it will be our job, it seems, if we are up to it, to pick whatever natures and whatever kinds of natures are suited to the guardianship of our city.” “Our job, indeed.” “By Zeus,” said I, “we have not taken on some insignificant task. Nevertheless, as long as our powers do not fail us we must not lose heart.” “Indeed we must not,” said he.

^{375a}

“When it comes to guardianship,” said I, “do you think there is any difference in nature between a noble young hound and a well-born young man?” “In what sense do you mean?” “For instance, each of them, presumably, needs to be keen of sense and nimble in pursuit as soon as they perceive something;

strong too, if they need to fight it out with whatever they catch.” “Yes, all of this is needed,” said he.

375b

“And of course they will need courage too, if they are to fight well.” “Of course.” “Now, would a horse, a dog, or any living creature at all that is not spirited, be prepared to exhibit courage? Or have you not noticed that when irresistible and invincible spirit is present in any soul, it is fearless in the face of anything, and unconquerable too?” “I have noticed.” “Well, it is obvious what the guardian should be like in bodily attributes.” “Yes.” “And in the case of the soul, it should obviously be spirited.” “That too.”

375c

“So, Glaucon,” said I, “how will they avoid being aggressive towards one another and to the other citizens when they are, by nature, people of this sort?” “Not easily, by Zeus,” he replied. “And yet, they need to be gentle towards their own people and harsh towards their enemies or else they will not have to wait for other people to destroy them. No, they will do it themselves first.” “True,” said he. “So, what shall we do?” I said. “Where shall we find a character that is at once gentle and great in spirit? For the gentle nature is, presumably, opposite to the spirited.” “Apparently.”

375d

“And yet, if someone were deprived of either of these qualities, he would never make a good guardian. And yet it seems impossible to have them both, and consequently it turns out that it is impossible to be a good guardian.” “That is likely,” said he. I was perplexed, and having reconsidered what had gone before, I said, “It is only right, my friend, that we are in perplexity, since we have abandoned the image we were proposing.” “What do you mean?” “We did not notice that there are, after all, natures that possess these opposite qualities, natures we thought did not exist.” “Where?”

375e

“They may be seen in other animals too, and particularly in the one we were comparing to the guardian. Indeed you know, I presume, that in the case of noble dogs, their natural disposition is to be as gentle as they possibly can towards familiar people and those whom they recognise, and the very opposite towards those they do not recognise.” “I know, indeed.” “So, it turns out this is possible after all,” I said, “and what we are looking for in a guardian is not contrary to nature.” “It seems not.”

376a

“Now, in addition to being spirited, do you think our prospective guardian also needs this: to become a philosopher in his nature?” “In what way?” he asked. “I do not understand.” “This, too,” said I, “is something you will discern in dogs, and it is worthy of admiration in these animals.” “What is it?” “That when he sees someone he does not recognise, he is aggressive even before he has suffered any harm at all, but when he sees someone he recognises, he welcomes them, even if they have not yet done him any good. Have you never admired this before?” “I have not really given it much attention before now,” said he, “but it is obvious that he does something like this.”

376b

“And yet, this is evidently a delightful characteristic of his nature, and a truly philosophic one.” “In what way?” “In that he distinguishes,” said I, “on sight, between friend and foe on the sole basis of having knowledge of the former and being ignorant of the latter. Indeed, how could he not be a lover of learning, when he makes a distinction between his own and what is alien, based upon knowledge and ignorance?” “Of course,” said he, “how could he not be?” “And surely,” said I, “the lover of learning and the lover of wisdom are the same?” “The same, indeed,” said he.

376c

“Should we therefore propose, with confidence, in the case of a human being too, that someone who is going to be gentle to his own and to people he knows needs to be a philosopher and a lover of learning?” “Let us propose this,” said he. “Then someone who is to be a noble and good guardian of the city will, according to us, be a philosopher who is spirited, swift and strong by nature.” “Entirely so,” said he.

376d

“Since he would be a person of this sort, in what manner will such people be reared and educated by us? And is the consideration of this question of any use to us in bringing clarity to the question that lies behind all our considerations: in what manner do justice and injustice arise in a city? We do not want the argument to be inadequate, or to make it too protracted either.” And Glaucon’s brother said, “Yes, I expect that this particular consideration will help in this.” “By Zeus, Adimantus, my friend,” said I, “in that case we should not give up, even if it turns out to be a lengthy consideration.” “We should not, indeed.” “Come on then, let us educate these men in our discussion, as though we were telling a story and had ample leisure to do so.” “We should.”

376e

“So, what would their education consist of? Or is it hard to find anything better than what has been discovered through the passage of time? This, I presume, consists of physical training for the body, and music for the soul.” “It does, indeed.” “Well then, shall we start educating them in music prior to the physical training?” “Why not?” “And as part of music,” said I, “do you include verbal accounts or not?” “I do.” “Are there two kinds of accounts, one true, the other false?” “Yes.” “Should they be educated in both, beginning with the false ones?” “I do not understand what you are saying,” said he.

377a

“Do you not understand that we tell stories to children, at first? These, I presume, are generally speaking false, although there is truth in them too. And we make use of these stories with children before the physical training.” “This is so.” “Well, that is what I meant when I said that music should be taken up before physical training.” “Rightly so,” said he. “Do you not know that the beginning of any work is most important, especially in the case of ^{377b} anything young and tender, since that is when it is most malleable, and the imprint one may wish to impress upon it sinks in?” “Yes, exactly.” “So, shall we allow the children to hear any random stories, composed by anyone at all, and take beliefs into their soul that are, for the most part, opposite to the ones we will think they should have, once they have come of age?” “No, we shall not allow this at all.”

^{377c}

“Firstly, then, it seems we must watch over those who make up the stories, and we must accept whatever is well made, and reject whatever is not well made, and we shall persuade the nurses and the mothers to tell the accepted stories to the children and shape their souls with these, rather than shaping their bodies with their hands. But most of the stories that they tell nowadays should be rejected.” “What kind of stories?” he asked. “In looking at the greater stories,” said I, “we shall also be looking at the lesser ones. For the greater and the lesser should indeed have the same character and the same capability. Do you not think so?” “I do,” said he, “but I do not understand what you mean by the greater ones.”

^{377d}

“The ones that both Hesiod and Homer told us, and the other poets too, since these men presumably composed false stories which they recounted to mankind, and they still do.” “What kind of stories?” said he. “And what aspect of them are you criticising?” “The aspect,” said I, “which deserves most criticism primarily, and especially if someone tells the

falsehoods in an ignoble manner.” “What is this?” “It occurs when someone presents an image, in words, describing what the gods and heroes are like in an ignoble manner, like a painter who paints something that bears no resemblance to whatever he wishes to paint a likeness of.” “Yes, indeed,” said he, “it is only right to criticise this sort of thing. But how is this done, and what are the falsehoods like?”

377e

“First and foremost,” I said, “is the greatest falsehood of all, concerning the greatest personages of all, a falsehood that its narrator recounts in an ignoble manner, according to which Uranus performed the deeds that Hesiod says he performed, and Cronus in turn took revenge on him.²⁸ But the deeds of Cronus in particular, and what he suffered at the hands of his son, these, even if they were true, should not, I believe, be recounted freely and easily to unreflective young folk. No, they are best kept quiet. And if someone does need to relate them, they should be heard in secret by as few people as possible, after sacrificing not some common piglet, but an enormous beast that is hard to procure, so that the least possible number of people get to hear them.” “Yes, indeed,” said he. “These accounts really are hard to take.”

378a

“Yes, and they should not be told,” said I, “in this city of ours, Adimantus. Nor should it be said, within earshot of the young, that there is nothing out of the ordinary in acting unjustly in the extreme, nor again in punishing a father for his unjust actions in all sorts of ways, since in so doing he would be doing what the foremost and most important gods have done.” “No, by Zeus,” said he. “I myself do not think they are suitable material either.”

378b

“Nor,” said I, “should it be said that gods are at war with gods, and are scheming and fighting, since this is not true either.

Indeed, if we want those who are to guard our city to consider it a disgrace to hate one another easily, then we should not tell or depict stories of the battles of gods and giants – far from it – or stories of a whole variety of other enmities of gods and heroes with their kindred and family members. But if we are somehow going to persuade them that no citizen so far has hated another citizen, and that it is unholy to do so, then this sort of thing must indeed be said ^{378c} to the young by old men and women, and, as they get older, the poets should be compelled to compose speeches for them, adhering closely to this.

^{378d}

“Stories of Hera being tied up by her son, and Hephaestus being flung out of heaven by his father for trying to defend his mother when she was being beaten, and any battles of the gods that Homer has made up, these should not be admitted into our city, whether they have a deeper meaning or not. For the young person is unable to distinguish what is a deeper meaning and ^{378e} what is not, and whatever he incorporates into his beliefs at that age tends to become difficult to eradicate or undo. Surely then, for all these reasons, we should ensure above all that the very first stories they hear are the noblest stories they could possibly hear for the development of excellence.” “Yes, that makes sense,” said he. “But if someone were to press the point and ask us what we are referring to and what the stories are, what stories would we mention?”

^{379a}

And I said, “At the moment, Adimantus, you and I are not poets but founders of a city. Now, it is appropriate that the founders know the guidelines within which the poets should compose stories, and from which they should not deviate when they are composing. But it is not appropriate that the founders themselves make up stories.” “That is right,” said he, “but the question is what would be the guidelines in relation to descriptions of the gods?” “Somewhat as follows, I presume,”

said I. “The god should, of course, always be portrayed as he really is, whether a poet presents him in an epic, a lyric, or in a tragic work.” “Yes, that should always be the case.”

379b

“And since the god is actually good, should he not be spoken of as such?” “Of course.” “And, indeed, nothing that is good is harmful, is it?” “I do not think so.” “Now, can that which is not harmful do any harm?” “Not at all.” “And can that which is not harmful do anything bad?” “No, it cannot do that either.” “Yes, and whatever does nothing bad could not be the cause of anything bad either, could it?” “No, how could it?” “What about this? Is that which is good, beneficial?” “Yes.” “In that case, is it the cause of things going well?” “Yes.” “So, what is good is not the cause of everything. No, it is the cause of all that is well, but it is not the cause of bad things.” “Entirely so,” said he.

379c

“So, since the god is good,” I said, “he would not be the cause of everything, as most people say. No, to humanity he is the cause of very little, and there is a great deal he is not responsible for. Indeed, with us, what is bad far exceeds what is good, and we should declare that no one else is the cause of what is good except the god, and we should seek elsewhere for the causes of what is bad, and not blame the god.” “I think,” said he, “that what you are saying is entirely true.”

379d

“In that case,” said I, “we should not accept, from Homer or any other poet, this error about the gods, when he foolishly makes the mistake of saying that two pitchers ^{379e} *Stand on the floor of Zeus’ abode / They are filled with fates; / One with good, the other with wretched. / And he to whom Zeus gives a mixture of both / Sometimes meets with bad, sometimes with good / But he to whom Zeus gives, from the second jar, unmixed / Foul misery drives him over the divine earth.* Nor that Zeus is our steward of ‘good and bad alike’.²⁹

380a

“As for Pandarus and the violation of oaths and truces, if anyone says that Athena and Zeus brought this about they will not receive our praise, nor if they say that strife and contention of gods was caused by Themis and Zeus, nor indeed should we allow the young to hear, as Aeschylus maintains, that *God implants the cause in mortal men, / When he wants to utterly destroy a house*.³⁰ “If someone includes these lines in a play about the sufferings of Niobe, or of the family of Pelops, or of the Trojan war,³¹ or anything else like that, he should not be allowed to say that these are brought about by a god. And if they are to say this, they must come up with an argument, similar to the one we are looking for, and declare that the god was doing what was just and good, and the 380b sufferers derived benefit from being chastised. But the poet should not be allowed to say that those who paid this penalty were wretched, and the one who did all this was a god. But if he were to say that they were in need of chastisement because bad people are wretched and derive benefit from being made to pay a penalty by the god, that should be allowed. But the statement that a god is the cause of bad to anyone who is good must be opposed. We must do battle, by every possible means, against anyone saying this in his own city, if that city is to be well governed, or against anyone, young or old, even hearing such stories told, in verse or in prose, because if they were spoken they would be unholy utterances, of no advantage to us, not even concordant with themselves.” “On this law,” said he, “I am casting my vote with you, and I am pleased to do so.”

380c

“Well,” said I, “this would be one of the laws and guidelines concerning gods, on the basis of which the speakers will have to speak and the poets write their poems. The god is not the cause of everything, but only of what is good.” “And that,” said he, “is surely enough.” “Well, what about a second one as follows? Do you think that the god is a beguiler who can contrive to appear

in different forms at different times, sometimes actually changing his own form and passing into various shapes, at other times deceiving us and making us believe that this sort of thing is happening to him? Or is the god simple, and least likely of all to go away from his own form?" "I am unable," said he, "to give you a direct answer at the moment."

380d

"What about this? If anything is to depart from its own form, must it not be changed either by itself or by something else?" "It must." "Is it not the case that whatever is in the best condition is least subject to alteration and change by something else? For example, although a body is altered by food, drink and physical work, and any plant is altered by sunlight, the wind and other influences of this sort, the one that is healthiest and strongest is least subject to alteration, is it not?" "Of course."

380e

"And would not the bravest and most reflective soul be least troubled and subject to alteration by some external influence?" "Yes."

381a

"And presumably, in the case of all manufactured items too – equipment, buildings or garments – by the same argument those that are well made and in good condition are least liable to alteration by the passage of time, and any other influences." "Yes, this is so."

381b

"Then anything that is in good condition, by nature or by design or both, is most resistant to transformation by something else." "So it seems." "But surely the god, and what belongs to the god, is in the best possible condition in every way?" "Of course." "So in this respect, the god would be least inclined to adopt a lot of shapes." "Least, indeed." "In that case, would he transform and alter himself?" "Of course," said he, "if he is actually altered." "So, does he change himself into something better and nobler,

or into something worse and more base than himself?” “If he actually changes,” said he, “it must be into something worse, for we surely shall not maintain that the god is deficient either in nobility or excellence.”

381c

“What you are saying is absolutely correct,” said I. “And this being the case, do you think, Adimantus, that anyone, god or man, would willingly make himself worse in any respect?” “Impossible,” said he. “So it seems impossible,” said I, “even for a god, to wish to change himself. Rather, being as noble and excellent as it is possible to be, each of them always remains eternally in his own shape, purely and simply.” “Well, that seems absolutely necessary to me.”

381d

“So, best of men,” said I, “none of the poets should tell us that *Gods in the likeness of strangers / Assume all sorts of disguises, as they visit our cities.*³² “Nor speak falsely of Proteus and Thetis, nor introduce Hera in a tragedy, or any other works, transforming herself into a priestess, gathering alms for *The life-giving sons of Inachos, the river of Argos.*³³

381e

“And there are many other falsehoods of this sort that they should not tell us. Nor again should mothers, misled by these fellows, terrify their children by telling them bad stories in which some gods actually go about at night looking like various strangers of all sorts, lest the mothers speak ill of the gods, and at the same time make their children more cowardly.” “No, they should not do that,” said he. “But is it the case,” said I, “that although the gods themselves cannot undergo transformation, they make us think that they appear in lots of different guises, thus deceiving and beguiling us?” “Perhaps,” said he.

382a

“What about this?” said I. “Would a god be prepared to practise deception, either in word or in deed, by putting forth an

appearance?" "I do not know," said he. "Do you not know," said I, "that the true falsehood, if I may use such an expression, is hated by all gods and all humans?" "How do you mean?" he asked. "As follows," said I. "No one is prepared willingly to be deceived in what is presumably the most important part of themselves, about the most important matters. No, we are afraid most of all to have falsehood reside there." "I still do not understand," said he.

382b

"That is because you think I am saying something profound," said I. "I am just saying that being deceived in the soul in relation to things that are, and to have been deceived and be ignorant, and hold falsehood there and have it reside there is what everyone would find least acceptable, and it is in this case that they most detest falsehood." "Very much so," said he. "Then what I was saying just now was quite right. This ignorance in the soul of the person who is deceived may be called a true lie. For the falsehood in words is an imitation of the experience in the soul, an image that has arisen subsequently, and so it is not unadulterated falsehood. Is this not so?" "Entirely so." "Then the actual falsehood is hated, not only by the gods but by humanity too." "I think so."

382c

"But what about the falsehood in words? When and for whom is this useful, so that it does not merit our hatred? Is it not when it is used against enemies, or when some among the people we call friends, through madness or ignorance, are attempting to do some bad deed, and falsehood then becomes useful as a sort of medicine to prevent this? And in the stories we were speaking of just now, because we do not know the truth concerning events of the distant past, do we not make falsehood resemble the truth as best we can, and render it useful by so doing?" "Yes, indeed," said he, "that is what happens."

382d

“So then, in which respect would the falsehood be useful to the god? Is it because he does not know about past events, and therefore makes up falsehoods that resemble them?” “That would be quite ridiculous,” said he. “In that case, there is nothing of the deceiving poet in a god.” “I do not think so.” “Would he make up falsehoods because he is afraid of his enemies?” “Far from it.” “Would he do it because of ignorance or madness among those who are close to him?” “No,” said he, “no one who is ignorant or mad is beloved of god.” “So, there is no reason for the god to make up falsehoods.” “There is not.” “So, divinity and the divine are entirely devoid of falsehood.” “Entirely so,” said he.

382e

“So, the god is absolutely simple and true, in word and in deed, and he neither changes himself nor deceives others, awake or in a dream, through appearances, words or signs.” “Now that you say so,” said he, “that is how it looks to me too.” “In that case, do you agree that this is a second guideline by which we should speak and write poems about the gods? They are not enchanters who transform themselves, nor do they lead us astray with falsehoods through their words or their actions.” “I agree.”

383a

“So, although we praise a great deal that is in Homer, we shall not praise the part where Zeus sends that dream to Agamemnon, nor shall we praise Aeschylus when he has Thetis say that Apollo sang at her wedding, ‘to celebrate her goodly race of children’, ^{383b} *Their days prolonged, from pain and sickness free, / And rounding out the tale of heaven’s blessings, / Raised the proud paeon, making glad my heart. / And I believed that Phoebus’ mouth divine, / Filled with the breath of prophecy, could not lie. / But he himself, the singer, himself who sat / At meat with us, himself who promised all, / Is now himself the slayer of my son.*³⁴

383c

“Whenever someone says anything like this about the gods, we shall be angry with him and refuse to grant a chorus, nor shall we allow teachers to make use of this for the education of the young folk, if our guardians are going to become as god-revering and divine as it is possible for a human being to be.” “I agree entirely with these guidelines,” said he, “and I would use them as laws.”

BOOK III

386a

“Well,” said I, “these are the sort of things that should be heard about the gods, and the sort that should not, from their earliest childhood by those who are to show respect for the gods and for their own parents, and not make light of their friendship with one another.” “Yes,” said he, “and I think we are now looking at this in the right way.” “But what if they are to be courageous? Must they not be told these stories, and also the kind of thing that will make them least afraid of death? Or do you think anyone would become courageous 386b whilst harbouring this fear within himself?” “By Zeus,” said he, “I do not.” “What about this? Do you think anyone who believes in Hades and its horrors will be fearless in the face of death, and will choose death in battle in preference to defeat and slavery?” “Not at all.” “It seems, then, that we should also supervise those who turn their hand to telling these stories, and implore them not to speak ill of Hades’ realm in such a simplistic manner, but rather to praise it, since 386c what they are now telling us is neither true nor beneficial to those who are to become fighting men.” “We should, indeed,” said he. “So we shall erase everything of this sort,” said I, “beginning with the following verses: *I would rather follow the plough as thrall to another man, / one with no land allotted him and not much to live on, / than be a king over all the perished dead.*³⁵

386d

And this, ... *the houses of the dead lie open to men and immortals, / ghastly and mouldering, so the very gods shudder before them;*³⁶ And, Oh, wonder! *Even in the house of Hades there is left something, / a soul and an image, but there is no real heart of life in it.*³⁷ And this, To whom alone Persephone has granted intelligence / *even after death, but the rest of them are fluttering shadows.*³⁸ And, ... *and the soul fluttering free of his limbs went down into Death's house / mourning her destiny, leaving youth and manhood behind her.*³⁹

387a

And this, ... *but the spirit went underground, like vapour,*⁴⁰ And, And as when bats in the depth of an awful cave flutter / *and gibber, when one of them has fallen out of his place in / the chain that the bats have formed by holding one on another; / so, gibbering, they went their way together.*⁴¹

387b

“And we shall ask Homer and the other poets not to be angry if we strike out these verses and others like them, not because they are unpoetic or unpleasant for most people to hear, but because the more poetic they are, the less they should be heard by the young and by men who need to be free and more afraid of slavery than of death.” “Entirely so.” “What is more, should not all the terrible, frightening names associated with these realms be abolished too, names like ‘Cocytus’ and ‘Styx’,⁴² ‘the dead’ and ‘those beneath the earth’, and other names of this type that make anyone who hears them tremble? Perhaps they are good for some other purpose, but we are afraid that as a result of such trembling our guardians may become more excitable and softer than needs be.”

387c

“And we would be right to be afraid,” said he. “Should they be excluded?” “Yes.” “Then words that have the opposite effect should be used in common parlance and in poetry?” “Of course.” “Shall we also remove the lamentations and wailings of the famous men?” “We must,” said he, “in the light of the

previous exclusions.” “Then,” said I, “let us consider whether we are right to remove them or not. We maintain that a reasonable man will not think that dying is a terrible thing to happen to another reasonable man, who is also his friend.” “We maintain this, indeed.”

387d

“So, he would not lament, at least not for that man, as though something terrible had befallen him.” “Certainly not.” “In that case, we are also saying that as regards living well, a person like this is most sufficient unto himself, and in contrast to other people he is least dependent on anyone else.” “True,” said he. “So, to him, it is least terrible to be deprived of a son or a brother or money, or anything else like that.” “Least indeed.” “So, whenever some such misfortune overtakes him he laments least and bears it with the utmost gentleness.” “Very much so.”

387e

“We would be right then to take these dirges away from men of reputation, and we might give them to women, but not to women of substance, and to bad men, so that those whom we say we are rearing as guardians of their own country will be disgusted at the prospect of behaving like such people.” “We would be right,” said he. “Once again then, we shall ask Homer and the other poets not to have Achilles, the son of a goddess, *Lying now on his side, then again on his back, then face down, / then standing upright and roaming, distraught along the / shore of the unharvested ocean.*⁴³

388a

Nor say, *In both hands he caught up the grimy dust / and poured it over his head and face.*⁴⁴ Nor have him generally wailing and lamenting in the whole variety of ways that the poet makes him behave. Nor should he say Priam, a near relation of the gods, was making entreaties and *...wallowed in the muck before them, / calling on each man and naming him by his name.*⁴⁵

388b

But it is even more important that we ask them at least not to have gods lamenting and saying, ^{388c} *Ah me, my sorrow, the bitterness in this best of child-bearing.*⁴⁶ And even if he makes gods act like this, he certainly must not dare to portray the greatest of the gods so inaccurately that he says, *Ah me, this is a man beloved whom now my eyes watch / being chased around the wall; my heart is mourning for Hector.*⁴⁷ And, ^{388d} *Ah me, that it is destined that the dearest of men, Sarpedon, / must go down under the hands of Menoitios' son Patroclus.*⁴⁸ “For, dear Adimantus, if our young folk were to listen seriously to this sort of thing, and not deride these as unworthy utterances, they would hardly regard such behaviour as unworthy of mere mortals like themselves if it also occurs to them to say or do something like this. Instead, they would exhibit neither shame nor restraint in singing dirges and laments aplenty at the slightest mishap.” “What you are saying is very true,” said he.

^{388e}

“Well, we don’t want that, as the argument indicated to us just now, an argument in which we should place our trust until someone convinces us otherwise with a better one.” “Indeed, we do not want that.” “Indeed not, nor should they be too fond of laughter either. For whenever someone yields to violent laughter, this sort of thing involves a violent change.” “I think so,” said he.

^{389a}

“So, if someone portrays any human being worthy of note as overcome by laughter, that is unacceptable, and it is even more unacceptable in the case of gods.” “More unacceptable indeed,” said he. “In that case we shall not accept anything like the following verses about the gods, even from Homer: *But among the blessed immortals uncontrollable laughter / went up as they saw Hephaistus bustling about the palace.*⁴⁹ “According to our argument these should be rejected.”

^{389b}

“You may attribute that to me if you wish,” said he. “In any case it should not be accepted.” “But, of course, we must attach great importance to truth. Indeed, if we were right to say earlier that although falsehood is really of no use to gods it is still useful to humans, as a kind of medicine, then it is obvious that something like this should be entrusted to physicians, and that private citizens should have no involvement with it.” “Obviously,” he said.

389c

“It is appropriate, then, for those who rule our city, if anyone, to tell falsehoods in dealing with the citizens or in dealing with enemies for the benefit of the city, while it is not appropriate for anyone else to be involved in something of this sort. But for a private citizen to be false towards the rulers in particular is, we shall insist, as much, indeed a greater transgression than not speaking the truth to a physician when ill, or to a trainer during a training programme about the condition of his own body, or not informing a steersman about what is actually going on regarding the ship and the sailors, or his own level of experience or that of his fellow sailors.”

389d

“Very true,” said he. “So if the ruler catches anyone else in the city lying, whether *He is one who works for the people, either a prophet, or a healer of sickness, / or a skilled workman*,⁵⁰ he will punish them for introducing a practice that overturns and destroys the city, just like a ship.” “Yes,” said he, “if word is matched by deeds.” “What about sound-mindedness, then? Will not our young folk need this?” “Of course.” “And for most people, do not the most important aspects of sound-mindedness consist in being obedient to their rulers, and being rulers themselves over the pleasures of drink, sex and food?”

389e

“Yes, I think so.” “Then I think we shall declare that the sort of thing that Diomedes says in Homer, is well said. *Friend, stay quiet*

rather and do as I tell you;⁵¹ And the connected lines, *But the Achaian men went silently, breathing valour, / in fear of their commanders;*⁵² And anything else of this sort.” “Very well.” “What about lines like these: *You wine sack, with a dog’s eyes, with a deer’s heart...*⁵³ and the lines that follow? Are these, and any other insolent remarks directed by private citizens against their rulers, either in verse or in prose, good?” “They are not good.”

390a

“Indeed, I do not think they are appropriate for the young folk to hear, not with a view to sound-mindedness at any rate. Yet if they provide some other pleasure, that is no surprise. How does this look to you?” “As you say,” said he. “And what if he makes the wisest of men say that he thinks the most beautiful moment of all is when *...the tables are loaded with bread and meats, / and from the mixing bowl the wine steward draws the wine / and carries it about and fills the cups.*⁵⁴ “Do you think these lines are suitable for a young person to hear, if he is to develop self-control?

390b

Or indeed, *All deaths are detestable for wretched mortals, / but hunger is the sorriest way to die.*⁵⁵ “Or about Zeus, awake, alone, while the other gods and humans too are sleeping, quickly forgetting all the plans he had made, because of sexual desire; being so overcome at the sight of Hera that he could not even wait to get into their chamber, but wanted to have intercourse with her there and then on the ground; saying that he was never in the grip of such desire, not even when they first consorted together ^{390c} *Unbeknownst to their dear parents* “Nor about Ares and Aphrodite being tied up by Hephaestus for similar reasons.”⁵⁶ “No, by Zeus,” said he, “that does not seem suitable to me.” “But if some feats of endurance in the face of all sorts of trials are spoken of, and enacted by famous men, these should be seen and heard by our young folk. For example, ^{390d} *He struck himself on the chest and spoke to his heart and scolded it: / ‘Bear up, my heart. You have had worse to endure before this.’*⁵⁷ “Entirely

so,” said he.

390e

“Nor indeed should we allow such men to be corruptible by bribes, or be fond of money.” “In no way.” “So, no one should sing the line that says, *Gifts move the gods and gifts persuade dread kings*.⁵⁸ Nor should we praise Achilles’ teacher, Phoenix, as setting the standard when he advised him to accept gifts in return for assisting the Achaeans, and not to abate his wrath if no gifts were forthcoming. We shall not deem Achilles himself worthy of this, nor shall we accept that he was so ^{391a} fond of money as to take bribes from Agamemnon, or indeed to release a dead body if he was paid, but not otherwise.” “No,” said he. “It would not really be right to praise this sort of thing.” “And I am reluctant,” said I, “for Homer’s sake, to declare that it is unholy to say all this about Achilles, or to believe it when others say so, or indeed that he said to Apollo, *You have balked me, striker from afar, most malignant of all gods, / Else I would punish you, if only the strength were in me*.⁵⁹

391b

“Or that he was disrespectful of the river, a god, and was prepared to do battle against him; or again, that although his own locks were already promised to the other river, Spercheius, he said, ‘I would give my hair into the keeping of the hero Patroclus,’⁶⁰ even though Patroclus was a corpse. We should not believe that Achilles did this. And we shall deny that the dragging of Hector’s body around the tomb of Patroclus,⁶¹ and the slaughter of the prisoners of war over his funeral pyre,⁶² is ^{391c} true. Nor shall we allow our charges to be convinced that Achilles, the son of a goddess and of Peleus who was the most sound-minded of men, a grandson of Zeus, reared by the all-wise Cheiron, was so full of confusion as to harbour within himself two opposed diseases: a love of money that ill becomes a free man, and an arrogance towards gods and men alike.” “You are right,” said he.

391d

“Then we should not believe them,” said I, “nor should we believe, nor allow it to be said, that Theseus, the son of Poseidon, and Perithous, son of Zeus, embarked upon such awful abductions, nor that any other child of a god and a hero would dare to enact awful, impious deeds, the sorts that are falsely attributed to them nowadays. Rather, we shall compel the poets to declare either that the deeds were not theirs, or that those who performed them were not the children of gods. But they must not make both statements. Nor should they attempt to persuade our young folk that ^{391e} the gods give rise to evil, or that heroes are no better than mortal men. For as we were saying before, these claims are neither pious, nor are they true. Indeed we have shown, I presume, that it is impossible for evils to come from the gods.” “Of course.” “And what is more, they are harmful to those who hear them, since anyone will forgive himself for being bad once he is convinced that such deeds are performed and have been performed by *The near-sown seed of gods, / Close kin to Zeus, for whom on Ida’s top / Ancestral altars flame to highest heaven, / Nor in their life-blood fails the fire divine.*⁶³

392a

“That is why we should put a stop to stories of this sort, lest they engender a total indifference to degenerate behaviour, in our young folk.” “Yes, precisely,” said he. “So,” said I, “now that we are defining the kind of accounts that should be delivered, and the kind that should not, is there anything we have left out? We have said how the gods, daimons and heroes should be spoken of, and those in Hades too.” “Yes, indeed.” “So, what is left would be concerned with humans, would it not?” “Obviously.” “But, my friend, it is impossible for us to arrange this at the moment.”

392b

“Why so?” “Because I think we shall simply affirm that poets and prose writers do indeed speak ill of human beings on matters of the utmost importance. They say that although they are unjust, many of them are happy while the just people are wretched, that acting unjustly is profitable as long as it goes undetected, while justice is what is good for someone else but inimical to your own interests. And I think we shall forbid them to say this sort of thing and direct them instead to sing and tell stories that say the exact opposite. Do you not think so?” “I know full well,” said he.

392c

“In that case, if you agree that what I am saying is correct, may I claim that you have agreed on the issues we have been investigating all along?” “You have understood correctly,” said he. “Now, once we find out the sort of thing justice is, and how it is naturally beneficial to its possessor, regardless of whether he seems to be just or not, we shall then come to agreement on the sort of accounts that should be given about human beings, but not until then.” “Very true,” said he.

392d

“Well, let that be the end of our discussion of speeches, and in my opinion we should consider speech itself next. Then our consideration of what should be said and how it should be said will be a comprehensive one.” Then Adimantus said, “I don’t understand what you mean by this.” “Well, you do need to understand,” said I. “Perhaps you will get a better sense of it from the following. Is not everything that storytellers or poets say a narrative of events that have happened, are happening, or are going to happen?” “Yes, what else could it be?” said he.

392e

“Yes, and do they not proceed either by simple narrative, by narrative that takes place through imitation, or through both?” “I still need to understand this more clearly,” he said. “I seem,” said I, “to be a ridiculous teacher, devoid of clarity. So like those

who are unable to express themselves, I shall attempt to show you what I mean, not in full, but by taking a particular part of it. Tell me then, do you know the initial verses of the Iliad, where the poet says that Chryses begged Agamemnon to set his daughter free, but that Agamemnon was angry, and so Chryses, since he had been unsuccessful, called down curses from the god upon the Achaeans?"

393a

"I do indeed."

393b

"Then you know that up to the lines *he supplicated all the Achaians, / But above all Atreus' two sons, the marshals of the people*:⁶⁴ the poet himself is speaking, and he does not even attempt to give us the impression that anyone else is speaking except himself. But in the lines that follow these, he speaks as if he himself is Chryses, and he attempts as best he can to make us think that the speaker is not Homer but the priest, an old man. And all the rest of the narrative about events at Troy and Ithaca, and the entire Odyssey, has for the most part been composed in this way." "Yes, indeed," said he. "Now, it is narrative, is it not, on the occasions when he is speaking the speeches, and also when there is an interval between speeches?" "Of course."

393c

"But when he delivers a speech as though he were someone else, will we not then say that as best he can, he is making his own speech resemble that of the person who, he tells us, is about to speak?" "We shall say so. What of it?" "Does not the process of making oneself resemble another person, either in speech or in outward appearance, mean imitating the person one is making oneself resemble?" "Indeed." "So, in a case like this it seems that Homer and the other poets construct the narrative through imitation." "Entirely so."

393d

“But if the poet were not to hide himself anywhere, the entire poetic narrative would have proceeded without imitation. And in case you say once more that you do not understand, I will tell you how this may happen. Indeed, if Homer were to begin by saying that Chryses arrived as a supplicant of the Achaeans, and particularly of their king, bringing his daughter’s ransom, and he was to speak thereafter still as Homer and not as if he had become Chryses, you know that that would not be imitation but simple narrative. It would proceed somewhat as follows. I will deliver it in prose since I am no poet.

393e

“When the priest arrived, he prayed that the gods would grant them safe passage home once they had captured Troy, and that they would accept the ransom and free his daughter out of reverence to the god. Once he had said all this, everyone else was respectful and co-operative, but Agamemnon was annoyed, and he ordered him to depart there and then, never to return, or else his sceptre, and the garlands of his god, would not be enough to protect him. And he said that ^{394a} before he would release Chryses’ daughter she would grow old with him in Argos, and he ordered him to go away and not provoke him if he wanted to return home safely. The old man was terrified when he heard this, and he departed in silence. But once he was out of the Achaean camp he prayed profusely to Apollo, invoking the many names of the god and issuing reminders, asking to be repaid if any gifts he had ever given had pleased the god, either through building temples or sacrificing animals. In return for these, he prayed that the Achaeans would pay the price of his tears with the arrows of the god.

394b

“That, my friend,” said I, “is how a simple narrative proceeds in the absence of imitation.” “I understand,” said he. “Then you should understand,” said I, “that the exact opposite of this occurs when someone removes the intervening words of the

poet himself and leaves only the exchanges between the speakers.” “I understand this too,” said he. “This is the sort of thing that occurs in tragedies.”

394c

“You are quite right,” said I. “You have understood. And I think I am now clarifying for you what I could not clarify previously, that some poetry and storytelling proceeds entirely through imitation including, as you say, tragedy and comedy. The kind that proceeds through reports by the poet himself, you would find for the most part in dithyrambic poems,⁶⁵ while the kind that employs both is found in epic poetry, and in numerous other places too, if you understand me.” “Yes,” said he. “I now follow what you wanted to say then.”

394d

“And do you also recollect what went before, when we maintained that although we have already explained what should be said, we still need to consider how it should be said.” “Yes, I remember.” “Well, this is the point I was making, that we need to come to an agreement on whether we shall allow the poets to compose narratives for us by using imitation, or allow them to imitate in some cases but not in others, and the sort of cases we envisage, or, indeed, not allow them to imitate at all.” “I get the sense,” said he, “that you are considering whether we shall admit tragedy and comedy into our city or not.” “Perhaps,” said I, “and perhaps even more than these. In fact, I do not know yet, but we should go in whatever direction the wind of the argument carries us.” “Yes,” said he, “you put that nicely.”

394e

“Well, Adimantus, reflect upon this. Should our guardians be imitators or not? Or does this also follow from what we said before, that each particular person would be good at engaging in one particular pursuit, and not in many, and if he should attempt to turn his hand to lots of pursuits, he would fail to

achieve distinction in any of them.” “Of course it does.” “Does not the same argument apply also to imitation? It is not possible for the same person to imitate many things as well as he can imitate one thing.” “Indeed not.”

395a

“In that case, he will hardly engage in any pursuit worth mentioning, and simultaneously be an imitator imitating lots of things, when the same people cannot even do a good job of simultaneously producing two imitations that seem as closely related as comedy and tragedy for instance. You did refer to these two as imitations, did you not?” “I did, and what you are saying is true. The same people cannot compose both.” “Nor indeed can they be good rhapsodes and good actors at the same time.” “True.” “And the same people cannot be good actors in comedy and in tragedy too. And all these are imitations, are they not?” “Imitations.”

395b

“And it seems to me that human nature has been cut up into even smaller pieces than these, so that it is incapable of imitating many things well, or of properly enacting the very things that those imitations resemble.” “Very true,” said he. “So, if we are going to save our initial argument, according to which our guardians, set apart from all the other artificers, should be artificers of the freedom of the city in the strictest sense, and engage in no other pursuit that does not lead in this direction, then it is necessary that they neither ^{395c} enact nor imitate anything else. And if they are to imitate anything, they should, from their earliest childhood, imitate only what is appropriate to these artificers of freedom – men who are courageous, sound-minded, pious, free, and everything of this sort. But they will not enact, nor be clever at imitating, anything devoid of freedom, nor anything else that is shameful, in case they proceed ^{395d} from enjoying the imitation to enjoying the reality. Or have you not noticed that imitations that are

continued from our earliest years and beyond become established as habits and as nature at the level of body, speech and, indeed, of thought?" "Very much so," said he. "Then those whom we claim to care for," said I, "men who should themselves become good men, shall not be permitted to imitate a woman, old or young, railing against her husband, in conflict ^{395e} with gods, being boastful about it, and believing herself to be a happy woman; or when she is overtaken by misfortune, grief, or lamentation; and especially not when she is sick, in love, or in labour." "Absolutely," said he. "Nor should they imitate slaves, male or female, doing what slaves do." "No, they should not imitate this either." "Nor bad men either, it seems, nor cowards and those who do the very opposite of what we have ^{396a} said, reviling and ridiculing one another, using foul language when drunk or even when sober, full of the errors that such people fall into, in what they say or do to themselves or others. And I think they should not develop the habit of behaving like mad people, in word or in deed. For although they should be able to recognise mad and degenerate men and women, they should not do anything these people do, nor should they imitate them." "Very true," said he. "Well," said I, "should they imitate metal workers or other artificers, or those who row triremes, ^{396b} or those who shout orders to the rowers, or anyone else related to these activities?" "Indeed," said he, "how could they? They are not allowed to pay any heed to these matters at all." "What about horses neighing, bulls bellowing, rivers rippling, the sea roaring, thunder too, and indeed everything of this sort? Will they imitate these?" "No," said he. "They have been forbidden either to be mad or to imitate mad people."

^{396c}

"In that case," said I, "if I understand what you are saying, there is a particular form of speech and narrative in which the truly noble and good person would tell the story, whenever he had to say something, and there is also another form, unlike this one,

that someone opposite to this man in nature and upbringing would hold to, and in which he would tell the story.” “And what are these?” he asked. “I think,” said I, “that the moderate man, when it comes to the point in his narrative where there is some speech or action of a good man, will be willing to present this as though he himself was ^{396d} that person, and he will not be ashamed of this sort of imitation, especially when imitating a man acting resolutely and intelligently, and less so, and to a lesser extent, as he succumbs to disease, passion, drunkenness or some other affliction. But when it comes to someone unworthy of himself, he will not be prepared, seriously, to make himself like this inferior person, except perhaps briefly whenever he does something useful. Rather, he will be ashamed of being so unpractised at imitating people like this, and disgusted too at the prospect of moulding and adapting himself ^{396e} to the behaviour of people who are worse than himself. Unless it is just for fun, he is repulsed by the very thought.” “Quite likely,” said he. “So, will he not make use of the kind of narrative we described earlier when speaking of Homeric epic? And although his own speech will involve both imitation and the other form of narrative, will imitation not be a small part of the overall discourse? Or am I talking nonsense?” “This makes a lot of sense. This must be the type for a speaker like this.”

^{397a}

“Someone,” said I, “who by contrast is not like this. The more debased he is the more inclined he is to include everything in the narrative, and he will deem nothing unworthy of himself. So he will attempt, seriously and before large audiences, to imitate everything, including what we mentioned ^{397b} just now – thunder, the noise of wind, hail, axles and pulleys, the notes of flutes, of pipes and all instruments, and even the sounds of dogs, sheep, and birds. And in that case, will all this person’s exposition be through imitation by voice and by gesture, or will it include a small element of simple narrative?” “It must include

this too,” said he. “Well,” said I, “these are the two forms of exposition I was speaking of.” “They are, indeed,” said he.

397c

“Now, does not one of these forms involve only minor variations? And once someone imparts an appropriate harmony and rhythm to the exposition, since the variations are minor, does not the person who delivers it correctly, deliver it largely according to the same harmony, a single harmony, and indeed in a rhythm that matches it, in like manner?” “Yes, precisely,” said he. “That is how matters stand.” “And what about the other form? Does it not require the very opposite, all the harmonies and all the rhythms, if it too is going to be delivered in its own way, because it has such a huge variety of forms?” “Yes, this too is very much how matters stand.”

397d

“In that case, do all the poets, or anyone who says anything, fall into one or the other of these two types of exposition, or make up some mixture of them both?” “They must,” said he. “So what shall we do?” said I. “Shall we admit all of these into our city, or one of the unmixed ones, or the mixed one?” “If I am to prevail,” said he, “it will be the unmixed imitator of the noble person.” “And yet, Adimantus, the mixed one is pleasing. And what is most pleasing of all to children, and to people responsible for them, and to the broad mass of people, is the very opposite of what you are choosing.” “Most pleasing, indeed.”

397e

“But perhaps you would maintain,” said I, “that this would not fit in with our constitution because there is no twofold man among us, or a manifold one either, since each engages in only one thing.” “Indeed not. This would not fit in.” “And is that not the reason why a city like this is the only one where we shall find the shoemaker being a shoemaker and not being a helmsman as well as making shoes, and the farmer being a

farmer and not being a juror as well as farming his land, and the soldier being a soldier and not being a businessman as well as acting as a soldier, and so on for everything else?" "True," said he.

398a

"Then it seems that if a man whose wisdom enables him to take on every possible shape, and to imitate anything at all, were to arrive in our city, anxious to put himself and his poems on show, we would fall down before him as though he were a sacred object, a wondrous and pleasing one at that. But we would say that there is no one else of this sort among the citizens of our city, nor is it permitted that there ever shall be. We would anoint his head with myrrh, and give him a garland of wool. But for our own benefit, we would ourselves employ the more severe and less pleasing poet and storyteller, who would imitate the exposition of the noble man for us, and he would deliver the speeches in accord with those types we ordained by law when we first set about educating our soldiers." "Yes, indeed," said he. "That is what we would do if it were up to us."

398b

"Well, my friend," said I, "at this stage, the aspect of music that concerns speeches and stories has probably been brought to a conclusion fully, since we have described what should be said and how it should be said." "Yes, I think so too," said he.

398c

"After this," said I, "is what remains the aspect that concerns the manner of song and melody?" "Of course." "Well, could not anyone at all discover by now what we must say about them, and what they need to be like, if we are going to be in harmony with what we said previously?" And Glaucon said, with a laugh, "Well, Socrates, I am afraid I am not included in this 'anyone at all'. At the moment at any rate, I am not really up to the task of deciding the sort of things we should be saying, although I do have my suspicions."

398d

“Surely,” said I, “you are fully up to the task of saying, firstly, that melody is composed of three things combined: speech, harmony and rhythm.” “Yes,” said he. “This I can say, at least.” “Well, insofar as it is speech, it does not differ at all from speech that is not sung. It needs to be delivered according to the same types we prescribed earlier, and in a similar manner, does it not?” “True,” said he. “And, indeed, the harmony and rhythm should follow the speech.” “Of course.” “But we did say that in the case of speeches we do not need to include dirges and lamentations.” “Of course not.”

398e

“Well, since you are musical, tell me. What are the dirge-like harmonies?” “The mixed Lydian harmony,” said he, “and the taut Lydian, and some others like these.” “Should these not be taken away,” said I, “since they are not even useful to women who are to be reasonable, let alone to men?” “Indeed.” “And, indeed, drunkenness, softness and idleness in our guardians is most unseemly.” “Of course.” “So which of the harmonies are soft and suited to drinking parties?” “Ionic harmonies,” said he, “and also some Lydian harmonies that are called ‘loose’.”

399a

“Well, my friend, could you make use of these for military men?” “Not at all,” said he. “Indeed, it looks as if you only have the Doric and Phrygian harmonies left.” “I do not know these harmonies,” said I, “but please leave one harmony which would appropriately ^{399b} imitate the sound and tone of voice of a courageous man, engaged in military activities, or in any use of force; a man who, even in failure, or when wounded, or facing death, or when some other misfortune befalls him, confronts the situation with steadfast endurance. And leave another one for this man when he is engaged in peaceful activity that is devoid of force, and voluntary; persuading or imploring someone, either by praying to a god, or instructing or

admonishing his fellow man; or when the roles are reversed, and he himself submits to someone else who is asking him for something, or instructing him, or persuading him to change his mind; acting according to his ^{399c} own mind in all these, without being boastful; conducting himself with sound-mindedness and measure, always prepared to accept the outcomes. So leave these two harmonies, one forceful, the other voluntary, that will best imitate the utterances of sound-minded, courageous men as they succeed and as they fail in their purpose.” “Well,” said he, “you are simply asking me to leave the ones I just mentioned.” “Therefore,” said I, “we shall not need to include many-stringed instruments that play all of the harmonies in our songs and melodies.” “No,” said he, “not as I see it.”

^{399d}

“Then we shall not encourage artificers of triangles, harps and all the other many-stringed instruments that play in lots of harmonies.” “Apparently not.”

^{399e}

“What about flute makers and flute players? Shall we also admit them into our city? Or is not the flute ‘many-stringed’ in the extreme, and are not the very instruments that play all of the harmonies just imitations of the flute?” “Of course,” said he. “Then the lyre and the cithara are left for use in the city, and in the countryside there would be pipes of some sort for the shepherds.” “Well,” said he, “that is what our argument is indicating.” “We are not really doing anything new, my friend,” said I, “just preferring Apollo and his instruments, to Marsyas and the instruments that belong to him.”⁶⁶ “By Zeus,” said he, “it seems we are not.”

^{400a}

“By the dog,” said I, “without noticing it, we have been thoroughly purifying the city again, the one we called luxurious a moment ago.” “Well, we are being sound-minded,” said he. “Come on, then,” said I, “let us also purify whatever is left. Yes,

indeed, after harmony we have the matter of rhythm, and we should not pursue complicated or variegated rhythmic units. We should rather look for the rhythms of a life which is orderly and courageous. Once we have seen these, the metrical foot must be made to follow the speech of such a person, and so should the melody, but the speech must not follow the foot and the melody. But it is your job to state what these rhythms are, just as you did with the harmonies.”

400b

“Well, by Zeus,” said he, “I cannot say. And although I can say, from observation, that there are three forms from which all rhythms are woven, just as there are four sounds which are the source of all harmonies, I cannot say what sort of life each imitates.” “Well,” said I, “we shall take advice from Damon on these and on which rhythms are suited to absence of freedom, to aggression and to madness, and what rhythms are to be left for their opposites.⁶⁷ I am not clear about this, but I think I have heard him referring to some military rhythm as 400c a compound, and as a dactyl and as heroic. I do not know how he arranged it, but up and down were made equal, passing into short and long, and I think he called one ‘iambic’, and the other one ‘trochaic’, and he assigned long and short to each. And in some of these he censured, or indeed praised, the tempo of the foot no less than the rhythms themselves, or else some combination of both. But as I said, we should refer all this to Damon, for a decision on this would involve a lengthy discussion. Or do you think otherwise?” “By Zeus, I do not.” “But we can decide that grace and lack of grace follow good rhythm and lack of rhythm.” “Of course.”

400d

“And, indeed, good rhythm follows beautiful speech and resembles it, while lack of rhythm follows the opposite. And the same goes for good harmony and lack of harmony, if rhythm and harmony do indeed follow speech, as we said earlier, and speech does not follow them.” “But of course,” said he, “these

must follow speech.” “But what about the manner of speaking,” said I, “and the speech itself? Do these not follow the disposition of the soul?” “Of course.” “And everything else follows the speech?” “Yes.”

400e

“So good speech, harmony and grace, and good rhythm, follow good disposition, not what is referred to as a good disposition as a euphemism for silliness, but a mind truly endowed with a good and noble disposition.” “Yes, entirely so,” said he. “Well, must not these be pursued everywhere by our young people, if they are to enact what is their own?” “Yes, these must be pursued.”

401a

“And surely painting and any craftsmanship of this sort is full of these. Weaving is also full of them, house building too, and indeed all production of any other items, even the nature of bodies and of anything else that grows, for good grace and absence of grace is inherent in all these. Indeed, the lack of grace, rhythm and harmony is the close kindred of bad speech and bad disposition, and the opposites are the close kindred and imitations of its opposite, a sound-minded and good disposition.” “Entirely so,” said he.

401b

“Well then, should we only oversee the poets, and compel them to portray the image of the good disposition in their poems, or else compose nothing in our city? Or should we also oversee the other artificers and prevent them from portraying this bad disposition – the unrestrained one, devoid of freedom and grace – either in images of living creatures, or on buildings, or in anything else they produce? And if they cannot comply, should we stop them from plying their trade in our city in case our guardians, feeding on images of evil in an evil pasture, grazing freely, day by day gradually picking up a great deal from many different sources, unwittingly accumulate a single great

evil in their own soul? Should we search, rather, for those artificers who are naturally capable of seeking out the noble and graceful nature so that our young folk, as though dwelling in a healthy region, may derive benefit from everything that impinges upon their sight or their hearing from the noble works of the place, like a breeze that bears health from a wholesome region and leads ^{401d} them unwittingly, from their earliest childhood, to an affinity with noble reason, and friendship and concord therewith?" "Yes," said he, "that would be the best way to rear them, very much so." "Well then, Glaucon," said I, "is this not why being reared in music is of supreme importance, because rhythm and harmony, more than anything else, sink into the innermost soul and fasten most powerfully upon her, bringing good grace and making her gracious, provided the person has ^{401e} been reared aright, and having the opposite effect otherwise? And it is also of supreme importance because the person who has been reared in this, as he should be, would quickly discern any deficiencies in whatever has not been well made or well wrought by nature, and being rightly dissatisfied he would praise and delight in whatever is good, receive this into his soul, and being ^{402a} nourished by it he would become noble and good. And he would rightly criticise whatever is base, and he would hate it, even as a child before he was capable of understanding speech, and when speech had finally come, someone reared in this way would welcome it most of all, recognising it because of its familiarity." "Yes," said he, "I think it is for reasons of this sort that there is upbringing in music." "So, it is like when we had an adequate understanding of reading and writing," said I. "Once we noticed that the individual letters, few in number, keep recurring in all of the words they occur in, ^{402b} we showed the same regard for them, whether they were observed in long words or short words, for we were eager to recognise them fully everywhere, because we were never going to be knowledgeable until we were able to do

this.” “True.” “And we will not recognise images of letters that appear somehow in water or in mirrors until we have first recognised the letters themselves, but both involve the same skill and practice?”

402c

“Entirely so.” “Well, then,” said I, “by the gods, can I say that in like manner we shall not become musicians, neither ourselves nor these guardians we say we should educate, until we can first recognise the forms of sound-mindedness, of courage, of freedom, of magnificence, and all that is akin to these, and, indeed, all the opposites of these, everywhere, in all the various places they appear, and can be aware of their presence wherever they are present, themselves and their images too, and show the same regard for minor instances as for major instances, because we believe that the skill and the practice is the same in each case?” “This must be so,” said he, “very much so.”

402d

“Well, then,” said I, “if beautiful qualities, internal to the soul, coincide in the external form and are in agreement and concord with those, and are of the same type, would not that be the most beautiful sight of all for anyone with eyes to behold?” “Very much so.” “And, indeed, what is most beautiful is most loveable?” “Of course.” “Then the musical person would love people who are most like this, and would not love someone who lacked such concordance.” “He would not,” said he, “not if the deficiency were related to the soul. However, if the deficiency were something related to the body, he would accept this and be prepared to embrace him.”

402e

“I understand,” said I, “that you have a favourite like this, or you once had one, and I accept your point. But tell me this. Do sound-mindedness and excessive pleasure have anything in common?” “How could they,” said he, “when excessive

pleasure, no less than excessive pain, drives a person out of their mind?” “Does it have anything in common with excellence in general?” “Not at all.” “What about violence and lack of restraint?” “Least of all.”

403a

“And can you name any pleasure greater or more intense than sexual pleasure?” “I cannot,” said he, “or a more manic pleasure either.” “But does not right love naturally love the orderly and the beautiful, with a sound mind and a musical spirit?” “Very much so,” said he. “So should anything manic, or anything akin to a lack of restraint, be involved in right love?” “No, they should not be involved.” “So this particular pleasure should not be involved, nor should a lover and beloved, who love and are loved in the right way, have any share in it.” “No, by Zeus, Socrates,” said he. “It should not be involved.”

403b

“And so, it seems, you will establish laws for the city we are founding, that a lover is to kiss, consort with, and touch his favourite, as a father would his son, for beauty’s sake, and only with his consent, and in general that a lover is to associate with anyone he is interested in, in such a way that their relationship will never seem to go beyond this, or else he will come in for criticism as an unmusical fellow with no sense of beauty.” “Quite so,” said he.

403c

“Well now,” said I, “does it look to you as though our account dealing with music is at an end? At any rate, it has ended where it should end. Surely, considerations of music should end in considerations of love of the beautiful.” “I agree,” said he.

403d

“After music, then, the young folk should be brought up in gymnastics.” “Indeed.” “Then, they should also be brought up systematically in this, beginning in childhood and continuing through life. And it consists, I believe, in the following; see if

you agree. Indeed, I am not of the view that if a body is sound, it makes a soul good by the body's own excellence, but on the contrary, a good soul renders a body as good as it can possibly be by the soul's own excellence. Is that your view too?" "That is how I see it," said he.

403e

"Well, would we be doing the right thing if we were to care for the mind properly, and then trust it to determine precisely what the body needs, while we provide instruction on the general guidelines, so that we do not have to give a lengthy account?" "Entirely so." "Well, we said that guardians must avoid drunkenness. For a guardian is surely the last person we would allow to get drunk, and not know where on earth he is." "Yes," said he, "it would be absurd that a guardian would need another guardian to look after him." "Well then, what about their food? Indeed, these men are athletes in a contest of the utmost importance, are they not?" "Yes."

404a

"In that case, would the condition of our modern athletes be suitable to these men?" "Perhaps." "But," said I, "this is a somewhat drowsy condition, and it is perilous to their health. Or do you not see that they sleep their lives away, and that the athletes themselves really become violently ill if they depart, even a little, from the prescribed way of life?" "Yes, I see this."

404b

"Then there is a need for some more refined training for our warrior athletes," said I, "who need to be like sleepless hounds whose sight and hearing are as keen as they can possibly be, able to undergo lots of changes on military campaigns – changes of water, of their general diet, of summer and of winter – without their health being in peril." "That is how it seems to me." "Now, would the best upbringing in gymnastics be closely related to the musical upbringing we described a little earlier?" "What do you mean?" "An appropriate gymnastic is also simple,

I presume, especially in the case of warfare.” “In what way?”

404c

“You could,” said I, “even learn this sort of thing from Homer. For you know that on campaign, at the feasts of the heroes, he does not feast them on fish, even though they are by the sea on the Hellespont, or on boiled meats, but only on roast meats, which are easier for soldiers to provide, since generally speaking it is easier to arrange to use a simple fire than to carry cooking equipment around with you.” “Very much so.” “Nor, I believe, does Homer ever mention sauces. And does not anyone who is in training know that if his body is to be in good condition, he should abstain from everything of this sort?” “Yes, they know,” said he, “and they abstain, and rightly so.”

404d

“And if you think these are right, my friend, it seems you will not praise Syracusan cuisine or Sicilian cookery in all its variety.” “I think not.” “Then you will not recommend a Corinthian maiden as a lady friend for men whose body is to be in good condition.”

404e

“Absolutely not.” “Nor the famed delights of Attic pastries?” “I must agree.” “Yes. And on the whole, I think, we could liken a diet and a lifestyle of this sort to melody and song that employs all the modes and all the rhythms, and the comparison would be correct.” “Of course.” “Did not variety engender lack of restraint in that case, while in this case it engenders disease? And simplicity in music engenders sound-mindedness in souls, while simplicity in physical training engenders health in bodies?” “Very true,” said he.

405a

“And when lack of restraint, and diseases, multiply in a city, do not law courts and medical centres open their doors in large numbers, while courtroom oratory and medical skill take on a great solemnity when lots of people, even free men, get

extremely serious about them?” “What else are they to do?”

405b

“But can we get any greater evidence of the bad and disgraceful system of education in a city than the fact that first-rate physicians and legal practitioners are needed, not only by the ordinary folk and the manual labourers, but also by those who pretend to have been brought up in the guise of free men? Or do you not think it is a disgrace, and strong evidence of a lack of education, to be compelled to use justice brought in from other people, who act as your masters and judges, because you do not have any resources of your own?” “It is the most disgraceful thing of all,” said he.

405c

“Or do you think,” said I, “that it is even more disgraceful when someone not only spends most of his life defending himself or prosecuting others in court, but is even persuaded, because he has no sense of nobility, to pride himself on this very fact; on being clever when it comes to acting unjustly and well up to the task of exploring every twist and turn and every possible escape route to wriggle his way out, and avoid facing justice; doing all this for the sake of worthless trivia, ignorant of how much better and more noble it would be to provide himself with a life that did not depend upon the somnolence of a juror.” “No,” said he. “This is even more disgraceful than the other example.”

405d

“And do you not think,” said I, “it is a disgrace to need a physician, not because of injuries or some seasonal diseases you have caught, but due to idleness and the sort of lifestyle we were describing: being filled with fluids and gases like some sort of swamp, compelling the refined Asclepiads to come up with names for diseases, such as flatulences and catarrhs?” “Yes, indeed,” said he. “These really are novel and unusual names for diseases.”

405e

“The sort of diseases,” said I, “that in my view did not exist in Asclepius’ time. My evidence for this is that at Troy, his own sons did not find fault with the women who gave Pramnian wine, sprinkled lavishly with barley and grated cheese, to the wounded Eurypylus, even though these are believed to produce inflammation. Nor did they criticise Patroclus, who was responsible for the treatment.”⁶⁸ “Yes,” said he. “That certainly was a strange potion for someone in that predicament.”

406a

“Not if you recognise”, said I, “that this fostering of diseases that is fashionable in modern medicine was not used by the Asclepiads of former times, not until Herodicus arrived on the scene.”⁶⁹ But Herodicus was a physical trainer, and when he himself fell ill he mixed his physical exercise with medicine, and tormented himself first and foremost, and then did the same to lots of other people.”

406b

“In what way?” he asked. “He turned his own death,” said I, “into a lengthy process. For although he paid minute attention to the disease, which was a fatal one, he was, I believe, unable to cure himself, and he lived his entire life under medical treatment with no time for anything else, tormented if he departed at all from his usual lifestyle. So, struggling against death, aided by his wisdom, he managed to reach old age.” “So,” said he, “he won a beautiful prize from his skill.”

406c

“A fitting prize,” said I, “for someone who failed to recognise that Asclepius was not ignorant or lacking experience in this form of medicine when he did not teach it to his offspring. Rather, he knew that everyone living under good laws is each assigned a single task in the city which he must work at, and no one has time to spend his life being ill and being treated for an illness. And it is laughable that we are aware of this in the case of the craftsmen, and do not notice it in the case of the wealthy

people, who are regarded as fortunate.” “How so?” said he.

406d

“Well,” said I, “when a carpenter is ill, he expects the physician to give him medicine to drink as an emetic for the disease, or apply a purgative, or to get rid of it by burning or cutting. But if someone prescribes a lengthy regimen for him, placing felt hats on his head and so on, he quickly says that he has no time to be ill, nor is it worth his while to live in that way, preoccupied with a disease ^{406e} and neglecting the function that is in front of him. With that, he bids farewell to physicians of this sort, resumes his usual lifestyle, and either gets healthy and lives on doing his own work, or else, if his body cannot take the strain, he dies and is quit of his troubles.” “Well,” said he, “that seems to be the proper approach to medical treatment for someone like this.”

407a

“So,” said I, “was that because he had a function to perform, and it was not worth his while being alive if he could not perform it?” “Of course,” said he. “But the wealthy man, as we say, has no function of this sort set before him, one that makes life unliveable if he is compelled to give it up.” “Indeed not. That is what people say, at any rate.” “Do you not listen to Phocylides,”⁷⁰ said I, “who says that once someone has a livelihood he should practise excellence?” “Yes,” said he, “and I think even before then.”

407b

“Let us not fight with him about this,” said I. “Instead, let us teach ourselves whether a wealthy person should practise this, and whether life is worth living for someone who does not do so. Or is the fostering of diseases an impediment to the application of the mind to carpentry and the other skills, while it does not prevent us from adhering to the injunction of Phocylides.” “Yes, by Zeus,” said he. “Excessive attention to the body, beyond simple physical training, is almost the greatest impediment of them all. In fact, it is troublesome in running a

household, in military campaigns, and in positions of authority in the city.”

407c

“But then, what is most significant is that it makes any kind of learning, reflection or attention to oneself hard. It is constantly suspecting some tension or dizziness of the head, and blaming this on philosophy. And so it acts as a total impediment to practising and testing excellence in this way, for it constantly makes a person believe he is sick, and makes him agonise incessantly about his body.” “Quite likely,” said he.

407d

“Should we maintain that Asclepius recognised all this too? There are those whose bodies are naturally healthy and have a healthy lifestyle, but have contracted some specific disease, and it was for these people, in this condition, that he devised medicine, for getting rid of diseases through ^{407e} drugs and surgery, prescribing their accustomed lifestyle so that he would not damage the public affairs of the city. While in the case of bodies that are diseased through and through, he did not attempt to contrive a long, bad life for the person, by gradually pouring things in and draining things out, enabling him in all likelihood to produce more sickly offspring of this sort. Rather, he did not believe he should treat someone who was unable to live his life normally, following the established course, since this would not be worthwhile either for himself or the city.” “You are saying,” said he, “that Asclepius was a statesman.”

408a

“Of course,” said I, “and his children too, because of the sort of man he was. Or do you not see that at Troy they proved themselves to be good at warfare, and they practised medicine in the way I described it? Or do you not also recall that in the case of Menelaus’ wound, the one Pandarus inflicted on him, ‘They sucked the blood and soothing simples sprinkled’,⁷¹ but they did not prescribe what he should drink or eat afterwards,

any more than they did for Eurypylus, since the drugs were quite sufficient to cure a man who had a healthy and orderly lifestyle before he was injured, even if he happened to take a barley, cheese and wine drink afterwards. However, they thought that it was not worthwhile, either for himself or anyone else, that someone who is diseased by nature, and lacking in restraint, should live on. They decided that their skill should not be applied to people like this, and that they should not treat them, even if they were wealthier than Midas.”⁷²

408b

“You are saying,” said he, “that the sons of Asclepius were men of great refinement.” “Appropriately so,” said I. “And yet, the tragedians, and Pindar too, are unconvinced by us,⁷³ and they maintain that although Asclepius was a son of Apollo, he was bribed with gold to cure a wealthy man who was already at the point of death, and for this, they say, he was struck by a thunderbolt. Whereas we, adhering to what we said before, are unconvinced by either of their claims. Rather, if he was the son of a god, we shall maintain that he was not corruptible, and if he was corruptible, he was not the son of a god.”

408c

“Well, you are quite right about that,” said he. “But what point are you making here, Socrates? Should we not have good physicians in our city? And presumably the best qualified doctors would be the ones who had treated the greatest number of healthy people, and sick people too. And the same would go for jurors. The best would have consorted with a whole range of people of all sorts and varieties.” “I am referring to good ones, very much so,” said I. “But do you know who I regard as good?” “I would if you told me,” said he.

408d

“I will try,” said I. “But you were asking about two dissimilar cases in the same question.” “How so?” he asked. “Physicians,” said I, “become highly accomplished if, beginning in childhood,

besides learning their skill, they also deal with as many bodies as possible of the most degenerate kind, and have themselves suffered from all these diseases and are, by nature, utterly unhealthy. For I do not ^{408e} believe they treat a body using their own body. Indeed if that were the case, their bodies could never be allowed to be in a bad condition, or to become so. But they treat a body using their own soul, which cannot be allowed to become bad, or to be so, if it is to carry out the treatment well.” “Correct,” said he. “But a juror, my friend, rules over a soul using his own soul, which should not be allowed, from its earliest years, to be reared among degenerate souls, to consort with them, act unjustly itself, and systematically go through all the injustices, so that it may, with a keen eye, detect the injustices ^{409a} of others, like bodily diseases. It must, rather, from its earliest years, have no experience of evil dispositions and be uncontaminated by them if it is to be noble and good and deliver sound judgements as to what is just. That is why the most suitable candidates appear simple-minded when they are young and are easily deceived by unjust folk, since they do not have patterns within themselves that resemble the responses of the evil doers.” “Yes, indeed,” said he, “that certainly is what happens to them.”

^{409b}

“That is why,” said I, “a good juror should be old rather than young, someone who has learned late in life what injustice is by realising that it does not belong in his own soul, and practising for a considerable time being fully aware of it as something alien, present in alien souls as an innate badness. To this knowledge he should have recourse rather than his own direct experience.” “Well, a juror like this,” said he, “seems to be the noblest kind of all.”

^{409c}

“And good too,” said I, “which is what you were asking about. For anyone who has a good soul is good. But that clever fellow

with a suspicious mind who has done a lot of evil deeds himself, who is cunning and thinks he is wise when in the company of people like himself. appears clever when he is being cautious, and looks to his own internal patterns. But when he is alongside good ^{409d} people or his elders, at that stage, by contrast, he appears stupid by being unnecessarily suspicious, unable to recognise a healthy disposition because he does not possess patterns of this sort. But since he meets degenerate people more often than worthy people, he seems to himself and to others to be more wise rather than more foolish.” “Yes,” said he, “that is true, entirely so.”

^{409e}

“Well, then,” said I, “we should not seek out a juror of this sort. If we want a good and wise one we should seek the previous sort. For degeneracy would never recognise both excellence and itself. But natural excellence may be educated, over time, to apprehend both itself and degeneracy simultaneously. So this person as I see it, and not the bad person, turns out to be wise.” “That,” said he, “is the way I see it too.”

^{410a}

“Will you not prescribe laws for our city, instituting medicine as we described it, alongside this sort of judicial practice? Will these treat those citizens of yours whose bodies and souls are naturally good, and if this is not so, allow those who are naturally bad in body to die off, while they themselves put to death those who are naturally bad in soul and incurable.” “This is apparently,” said he, “what is best both for the people in this predicament and for the city.” “And so,” said I, “your young folk of course will be careful not to need a judicial process like this, by making use of that simple music which, we say, engenders sound-mindedness.” “Indeed,” said he.

^{410b}

“And will not the musical person, by following the same trail as in the case of physical training, if he wishes, understand how to

avoid the need for medical treatment except when it is necessary?" "It seems so to me, at any rate." "Even the physical training itself, and the exercises, are something he will work at with the spirited aspect of his nature rather than physical strength in view, unlike other athletes who make use of diet and exercise for the sake of strength." "Quite right," said he.

410c

"In that case, Glaucon," said I, "is it not the case that those who established education in music and physical training did not do so with the intention that some people assume, that one would treat the body while the other would treat the soul?" "What was their intention then?" he asked. "It is most likely," said I, "that they established both, mainly for the sake of the soul." "How so?" "Have you not noticed how the mind itself is affected in people who devote themselves throughout ^{410d} their lives to physical exercise, and have nothing to do with music, and in those who do the exact opposite?" "What are you referring to?" he asked. "A fierceness and hardness in one case, and a softness and gentleness in the other," said I. "I have noticed," said he, "that those who devote themselves exclusively to physical training turn out fiercer than they should be, while those who do so in the case of music become softer than is good for them." "And, indeed," said I, "the fierceness is derived from the spirited part of the nature, and, given the proper nurture, it would constitute courage, but if it becomes more intense than it should, it would likely become hard and harsh." "That is how it seems to me," he said.

410e

"What about this? Would not the philosophic nature be associated with the gentleness, and if this is relaxed too much will it not be softer than it should be? And if it is properly nurtured will it not be gentle and orderly?" "Quite so." "And we are saying that our guardians should possess both of these natures?" "They should." "And should not the two be in

harmony with one another?” “Of course.” “And where there is such harmony, the soul is sound-minded and courageous?” “Entirely so.” “And where there is disharmony, it is cowardly and harsh?” “Very much so.”

411a

“Now, is it not the case that whenever someone surrenders to music, to be charmed by the flute sounds pouring into his soul through the ears as if through a funnel, pouring in those sweet, soft, dirge-like harmonies we spoke of just now, and lives his whole life humming delightedly in song, this man, if he possesses a spirited part, softens it at first, like iron, and renders it useful instead of being useless and brittle? But when he pours music in unceasingly, and it works its charms, he then proceeds to melt his spirit, turn it to liquid, until he finally dissolves it away as if he were ^{411b} severing the very sinews of his soul, and turning it into a ‘feeble warrior’.”⁷⁴ “Entirely so,” said he. “Now, if he were endowed by nature,” said I, “from the very outset, with a soul devoid of spirit, this would happen very quickly. But if it were spirited, having weakened the spirit he would render the soul unstable, quick to quarrel over trivia, and just as quick to calm down. So he becomes bad-tempered and irascible, rather than spirited, and he is filled with discontent.” “Yes, exactly.”

411c

“And what if someone, in contrast, works hard at physical training, feeds himself well, very well, but refrains from music and philosophy? At first, because his body is in such good shape, will he not be filled with confidence and spirit, and become more courageous than he was before?” “Very much so.” “And what if he practised nothing else, and had no communion with a Muse at all? Even if there was some love of learning in his soul, since it never gets a taste of learning or of enquiry, and is never involved in discourse, or music in general, will it not become weak, deaf and blind, since it is never awakened or nourished,

and its awareness is never purified?" "Just so," said he.

411d

"Then a person like this becomes a hater of discourse, and is devoid of music. He no longer uses ^{411e} verbal persuasion, but he gets results in everything through force and violence, like some wild animal, and he lives his life in ignorance and ineptitude, without any rhythm or grace." "That is it," said he. "Entirely so." "Well, since there are it seems these two, the spirited and the philosophic, I would say that some god has given humanity two skills, music and physical training, aimed at the spirited and the philosophic, not at the soul and the body except incidentally, but at these two so that they may be harmonised with one another, by tightening and slackening them to the appropriate extent."

412a

"Yes, it seems that way," said he. "So, the person who blends physical training most beautifully with music, and applies them to the soul with the utmost measure, is the one we may rightly declare to be perfectly musical and well harmonised in the highest degree, much more so than anyone who tunes the strings of an instrument." "Quite likely, Socrates," said he.

412b

"In that case, Glaucon, will we not always need some overseer of this sort in our city, if our constitution is to be preserved?" "Yes, indeed, we shall need this most of all." "These then, would be the guidelines for their education and upbringing. Indeed why would anyone itemise the dances, hunts, chases, athletic contests, and horse races that people like this would have? Surely it is quite obvious that these must adhere to those guidelines, and should no longer be hard to discover." "Probably not," said he.

412c

"So be it," said I. "Well then, what should we decide next? Will we not need to decide which of these same people will rule, and

which of them will be ruled?" "Of course." "Is it obvious that the rulers should be older, and those who are ruled should be younger?" "It is obvious." "And is it not obvious that the best of them should rule?" "That is obvious too." "But do not the best of the farmers turn out to be the most accomplished at farming?" "Yes." "And now, since these must be the best of our guardians, will they not be the most accomplished at guarding our city?" "Yes." "And must they not be intelligent in this role, and capable, and still care for the city?"

412d

"That is it." "But someone would care most for that which he actually loves." "Necessarily." "And, indeed, he would love this most once he believes that whatever benefits the city also benefits himself, and thinks that when it does well, he himself does well too, and if it does not, he does not." "Quite so," said he. "Then, we should select men of this sort from among the other guardians, men who, as we watch 412e them throughout their entire lives, seem to us to be entirely eager to do whatever benefits the city, and unwilling under any circumstances to do anything that does not." "These are suitable for selection," said he. "Then, I think they need to be watched at all stages of their lives to see that they guard this precept well, and are never charmed, or forced to forget and cast aside the opinion that they should do what is best for the city."

413a

"What do you mean," said he, "by 'cast aside'?" "I shall tell you," I replied. "It seems to me that opinion departs from the mind either voluntarily or involuntarily: voluntarily when false opinion departs from someone who learns better, involuntarily in the case of any true opinion." "I understand the case where it is voluntary, but I need you to explain the case where it is involuntary." "What about this? Do you not believe," I said, "that people are deprived of what is good involuntarily, and of what is bad voluntarily? And is it not bad to be deceived in

relation to the truth, and good to have the truth? Or do you not think that to have the truth is to think things that are?"

413b

"Yes," said he, "what you are saying is right, and I think they have been deprived, involuntarily, of true opinion." "Does this not happen to them when they are robbed, harmed or forced?" "Now, this I do not understand either," said he. "Perhaps," said I, "I am speaking in a lofty, tragic style. Indeed by 'robbed' I mean those who are persuaded to change their minds, or who are made to forget, because time in the latter case, and discourse in the former case, takes something from them without their noticing. So I presume you understand now." "Yes."

413c

"And by 'those who are forced' I mean those whom pain or distress would induce to change their minds." "Yes, I understand that too, and what you are saying is correct." "Those who are charmed, I think you would agree, are those who change their opinions when beguiled by pleasure or intimidated by some fear." "Indeed," said he, "everything that deceives people seems to charm them." "Well then, as I was saying just now, we should seek out some who are the best guardians of their own precept, according to which they should, on every occasion, do whatever seems best for the city. So, they should be watched from their very earliest years, setting them tasks in which someone would be most inclined to forget such a precept and be deceived. And we should select those whose memory holds and who are difficult to deceive, and reject anyone who is not like this. Is this so?"

413d

"Yes." "And we should also assign hard work, tribulations and trials to them, in which we should watch for these same qualities." "Rightly so," he replied. "Now," said I, "we should also devise a third kind of test in relation to being charmed, and

we should watch what happens. Just as people expose young horses to noise and commotion to see if they are fearful, so too, whilst still young, our guardians should be brought into fearful circumstances and then transferred into situations of pleasure, and thus be tested far better than gold is ^{413e} tested in the fire. And if someone is evidently resistant to charms, dignified in everything, a good guardian of himself and of the culture he has come to understand, adhering to good rhythm and harmony in himself under all these circumstances, he would then be of the greatest service, both to himself and to the city. And someone who is tested continually, as a child, as a youth and as a man, and emerges without taint, should be installed as a ruler and guardian of the city, and should be given honour in life and after death by assigning the most revered of our tombs and other memorials to him, while someone who is not like this should be rejected.

^{414a}

“So, Glaucon,” said I, “I think this is the selection and appointment process for our rulers and guardians. It is just an outline, not a detailed description.” “Well,” said he, “that is how it appears to me too.”

^{414b}

“In that case, would it, in truth, be most correct to refer to these people as guardians in every respect, both in relation to enemies from outside and friends within, so that the friends will not wish to do anything bad and the enemies will be unable to do so, while the younger people, whom we were calling guardians just now, are referred to as auxiliaries, who support the precepts of the rulers?” “Yes, I think so,” said he.

^{414c}

“Is there any way,” said I, “we might contrive one of those lies we were referring to earlier, the ones that arise in response to a need, a single noble lie to persuade the rulers themselves for the most part, or, failing that, persuade the city in general?”

“What sort of lie?” said he. “It is nothing new,” said I. “Yes, it is something from Phoenicia,⁷⁵ which has happened in many places already, as the poets maintain, and has convinced people. But it has not happened in our time, nor do I know if it could happen, and to convince people would require a lot of persuasion.” “You seem to be speaking with some reluctance,” said he. “My reluctance,” said I, “will seem quite reasonable once I have said what I have to say.” “Speak on,” said he, “and have no fear.”

414d

“I will tell you, then, even though I do not know where to find the audacity or the words to use, and I shall attempt firstly to persuade the rulers themselves and the soldiers, and then the rest of the city, that in fact all the education and upbringing we gave them was just like a dream. They imagined they were experiencing all this and that this was happening to them, but in truth they were under the earth at the time, being moulded and nurtured within her, and both themselves and their armour and the rest of their equipment was being manufactured. And once they had come ^{414e} fully to completion, the earth, their mother, sent them forth. And now they are to plan for and defend the place they are in, as though it were their mother and their nurse, if anyone goes against her. And they are to think of all the other citizens as their brothers and sisters, sprung from the self-same earth.” “No wonder you were ashamed to recount this lie,” said he.

415a

“Quite reasonably so,” said I, “but nevertheless, listen to the rest of the story. Yes, indeed, all who are in the city are brothers, that is what we shall tell them in our story. But as the god fashioned you, he mixed in gold in the generation of those of you who are up to the task of being rulers, and because of this such people are valued most. In the case of the auxiliaries, he mixed in silver, and he used iron and bronze in the case of

farmers and other artificers. Now, since you are all kindred, ^{415b} you would, for the most part, produce offspring like yourselves. Yet there are times when silver could be born from gold and there could be golden offspring from silver, and all the others could spring from one another in the same way. So, the god first and most emphatically proclaims to the rulers that they should be good guardians of nothing else, and should watch over nothing as intently as they watch the offspring in case there be any admixture of these other metals in their souls. And ^{415c} if their offspring is born with an admixture of bronze or of iron, they will not act out of pity in any way. Rather, granting them the respect appropriate to their nature, they will banish them to the ranks of artisans or farmers. Then again, if someone with an admixture of gold or silver is born among these, they will respect them and transfer some to the rank of guardians, others to that of auxiliaries, because there is an oracle according to which the city will be destroyed whenever an iron guardian or a bronze guardian guards her. Now, do you know any way that they might come to believe this story?"

^{415d}

"Not at all," said he, "not in the case of the people themselves. But perhaps their sons and the next generation, and humanity in general thereafter, might believe it." "But even this much," said I, "would work nicely to ensure that they show more care for the city and for one another. For I think I understand what you are saying fairly well. Indeed, this will ^{415e} unfold in whatever way human tradition may take it, while we lead out these earth-born men, fully armed, led by their rulers. And when they arrive, have them look about for the best place in the city to set up their military camp, a location from which they could exercise most control over the city's inhabitants in case anyone might be unwilling to obey the laws, a place from which they could also defend her against outsiders in case enemies might come upon her like a wolf upon a flock of sheep. And with

their camp established, having offered sacrifices to the appropriate gods, they could make places to rest. Or how do you see it?" "Just so," said he.

416a

"Will not such places be adequate to withstand the heat of summer and the cold of winter?" "Yes, they must be," said he, "since I think you are referring to their dwellings." "Yes," said I, "dwellings for soldiers rather than for money-makers." "Again," said he, "what distinction are you making between these two?" "I will try to explain this to you," said I. "Indeed, it is surely the most terrible thing of all and an utter disgrace for a shepherd to rear the sort of dogs that mind sheep in such a way that through indiscipline or hunger or some general defect of character, the dogs attempt to harm the sheep, and behave like wolves rather than dogs." "Terrible," said he, "of course."

416b

"So, must we not be on our guard in every way, in case these auxiliaries of ours do something like this to our citizens, because they are stronger than them, and become like harsh overlords rather than well-meaning allies?" "Yes," said he, "we must be on our guard." "Would they not have been provided with the greatest safeguard against this if they really had been properly educated?" "But surely they have been properly educated," said he. And I said, "This is not worth insisting upon, Glaucon, my friend. However, it is worth insisting upon what we said earlier, that they must have the right education, whatever that may be, if they are to possess the most important factor required to make them gentle, both towards themselves and towards the citizens under their guardianship."

416c

"And rightly so," said he. "And in addition to this education, anyone with any intelligence would maintain that they should also be provided with dwellings, and property in general, that does not prevent them from being guardians of the best

possible kind, and does not induce them to behave badly towards the other citizens.” “And he would be speaking the truth.”

416d

“Then see,” said I, “if they should live and be housed somewhat as follows if they are to be guardians of this sort. In the first place, none should possess any private property that is not absolutely necessary. Secondly, none of them should have a dwelling or storehouse that is not open to anyone who wants to go in. The necessities of life, as much as men in training for war who are both sound-minded and courageous require, these they will receive from the other citizens – as they stipulate – as a wage for guarding them, enough to last them no more than a year without any lack. And, like soldiers in a military camp, they should live life in common, and dine together at common tables.

416e

We shall tell them that they have gold and silver of a divine sort as a gift from the gods, always in their souls, and have no further need for the human sort; that it is an unholy act to pollute and contaminate that divine possession through the acquisition of mortal gold, because so much unholiness has arisen from dealing with the currency of the multitude, whereas the currency of these people is without taint; and that they are the only people in the city who are prohibited from handling or even ^{417a} coming into contact with gold or silver, or even from being under the same roof with them, from wearing them about their person, or drinking from a gold or silver vessel. “Accordingly, they would save themselves and save the city. But once they acquire land or houses or money of their own, they will then be householders or farmers rather than guardians, and will become slave-masters and enemies of the rest of the citizens rather than their allies. They will spend their entire life hating and being hated, conspiring and being conspired against, much more fearful of internal rather than external enemies, as

they run a course for themselves and the rest of the city that is already almost doomed to shipwreck.

417b

“So, for all these reasons,” said I, “let us declare that this is how the guardians should be provided with housing and with anything else, and let us establish these arrangements in law. Or do you not think we should?” “Entirely so,” said Glaucon.

BOOK IV

419a

Here Adimantus interrupted and said, “Now, Socrates, what would be your defence if someone were to maintain that you are not making these men very happy, and it is all their own fault, since, although the city is in truth theirs, they do not enjoy a single benefit from her, unlike their counterparts in other cities who own land, build beautiful grand houses, and acquire furniture to match, who offer private sacrifices to the gods, entertain guests, and, indeed, as you were saying just now, have acquired gold and silver and everything else that is supposed to belong to people who are going to be blessed? In fact, he might maintain, they look almost like paid auxiliaries who sit about ^{420a} in the city with nothing to do except keep watch.” “Yes,” said I, “and they do all this in return for their basic provisions, receiving no wages in addition to such provisions, as everyone else does. They will not even be able to travel abroad privately if they wish to, or pay for female companions, or indulge in other kinds of expenditure, like those who are generally regarded as happy. You are leaving out these objections, and a whole host of others like them.” “In that case,” said he, “let those objections also be included.” “So are you asking how we shall conduct our defence?” “Yes.”

420b

“We shall, in my opinion,” said I, “find whatever needs to be said by proceeding along the same track as before. Indeed, we shall say that it would be no surprise if these people, living in this way, are also the happiest people, even though we are not founding our city with a view to this so that one particular group among us will be especially happy, but so that the whole city will be as happy as it can possibly be. For we thought that in a city like this we would find justice to the greatest extent, and, by contrast, would find injustice to the greatest extent in the worst managed city, and, ^{420c} by observing them carefully, decide the issue we have been investigating for so long. At the moment then, we are, I believe, forming the happy city not by considering a few of its people in isolation, and proposing that people like this are happy, but by considering the whole city. We shall look at its opposite presently. “Indeed, it is as if we were painting a statue, and someone came along and said we were not using the most beautiful pigments on the most beautiful parts of the figure because we had painted ^{420d} the eyes, the most beautiful part, not with purple but with black. We would seem to be offering a reasonable defence by saying, ‘Strange man, do not presume that we should paint eyes so beautiful that they do not even look like eyes, and the same goes for the other parts too. But look and see whether we make the whole thing beautiful by applying the appropriate pigments to each part.’ “And, indeed, in the present case, do not compel us to attach happiness of this sort to our ^{420e} guardians, a happiness that will turn them into anything other than guardians. For we know we could dress our farmers in fine robes and deck them out with gold, and bid them work the land whenever they felt like it. We could have our potters recline by the fire, left to right, drinking and ^{421a} feasting, with the potter’s wheel beside them, to make as many pots as they felt like making. We could also make all the others happy in this way, so that the whole city would then be happy. But do not encourage us in this

direction since, if we take your advice, our farmer will not be a farmer, nor will our potter be a potter, nor will any of the other functions from which our city is constituted retain their character. “Now, in the case of the other functions, this is of less account, for shoe menders who are debased and corrupted, and who pretend to be shoemakers when they are not, are no threat to the city. But when guardians of the city and its laws seem like guardians when they are not, then, you see, they utterly destroy the entire city, and, what is more, they alone hold the key to the city being well governed and happy. So if we are producing true guardians of the city, who are least harmful to it, while our critic is referring to some farmers feasting at a festival, not in civic society, then he is describing something else besides a city.

421b

“So, we should consider whether to appoint the guardians with a view to providing them with the utmost happiness, or with a view to ensuring such happiness for the city as a whole, compelling or persuading our guardians to co-operate in this so that they will be the very best artificers of their own work, and the same will apply to all the others. And so, with the entire city flourishing and well managed, we should allow each of the types to have a share in happiness in the way that its nature allows.” “Yes,” said he, “this sounds well said to me.” “Well, then,” said I, “I wonder if the following point, related to this one, will sound reasonable to you.” “What is it?”

421c

“In the case of the other artificers, consider whether there are factors that corrupt them, so that they become bad artificers.” “What sort of factors?” “Wealth and poverty,” said I. “How so?” “As follows. Once he has become wealthy, do you think a potter will still be willing to attend to his craft?” “Not at all,” he replied. “Will he become lazy and less interested than he was before?” “Very much so.” “Will he not become a worse potter?” “That too,” said he, “very much so.” “Yes, indeed. And when,

due to poverty, he is unable to provide the tools or whatever else his craft requires, his workmanship will be poorer and he will teach his son and anyone else he instructs to be inferior artificers.

421d

“Indeed he will.” “Then, on account of both factors, poverty and wealth, what the crafts produce will be inferior and the artificers themselves will be inferior.” “Apparently.” “Then these, it seems, are additional factors which our guardians must watch out for by every possible means in case they creep into the city unnoticed.” “What sort of factors?” “Wealth and poverty,” said I, “since one produces luxury, idleness and disturbance, while the other leads to lack of freedom and bad workmanship, in addition to the disturbance.”

421e

“Entirely so, Socrates,” said he. “But please consider how our city will be able to go to war when it has acquired no wealth, especially if it is compelled to go to war against a large and wealthy city.”

422a

“It is obvious”, said I, “that it would be more difficult to fight against a single city like this, but against two such cities it would be easier.” “What do you mean?” said he.

422b

“Firstly,” said I, “if they need to do battle, will not they be fighting against wealthy men when they themselves are trained warriors?” “Well, yes,” said he. “This is so.” “Now, Adimantus,” I asked, “do you not think a single boxer, very well trained, could easily fight two rich, fat fellows who were not boxers at all?” “Probably not,” said he, “not at the same time, anyway.” “Not even if he were allowed to retreat,” said I, “and then turn around and strike the first man coming at him, and he were to do this repeatedly, under the baking sun? Would not a man like this ^{422c} get the better of quite a number of such fellows?”

“Indeed,” said he, “that would be no surprise.” “And do you not think rich people have more knowledge and experience of boxing than of warfare?” “I do,” he replied. “So, our trained warriors will easily do battle with two or even three times their own number.”

422d

“I shall concede the point,” said he, “for it seems to me that what you are saying is correct.” “What if we sent an embassy to the other city, telling them the truth: although we have no use for gold or silver, you do, so fight alongside us and take the wealth that the others have. Do you think anyone who heard this offer would choose to fight against tough, lean dogs, rather than fight alongside them against fat, soft sheep?” “No, I do not think so,” said he. “But if one city accumulates all the wealth of the others, watch out, in case it constitutes a danger to the one that is not wealthy.”

422e

“How fortunate you are,” said I, “that you think anything else deserves to be called a city except the sort we are equipping.” “What should we call it then?” he asked.

423a

“We should speak about the others,” said I, “as more than one city. For each of them is not a city, but a combination of many cities, as people say in jest, two at least – one of rich folk, the other of poor – both at war with each other. And in each of these, there are very many which you would be totally incorrect to regard as one. But if you regard them as many cities, distributing the wealth of some to the others, and the powers too, and even the people themselves, you will always have access to many allies and have few enemies. And as long as your city is managed sound-mindedly as was just arranged, it will be the greatest city, not in reputation, I do not mean that, but truly the greatest city, even if there are only a thousand defenders among her ranks. For you will not easily 423b find a single city

that is great in this way, among Greeks or non-Greeks, although there are many that seem to be many times greater than ours. Or do you think otherwise?" "By Zeus, I do not," said he. "Would this," said I, "not be the perfect criterion for our rulers in determining what size to make the city and, accordingly, the extent of the territory they should mark off, setting the rest aside?" "What criterion?" he asked. "I think it is as follows," said I. "Let it keep growing as long as it remains one city. It may grow thus far and no further."

423c

"That is a good way to proceed," said he. "In that case, should we give this additional instruction to our guardians: to be on their guard, in every respect, to ensure that the city be not small, nor seem to be great, but be one and sufficient?" "Quite a commonplace instruction, surely," said he. "And there is an even more commonplace instruction than this, which we mentioned previously, saying that it would be necessary, in situations in which any ordinary offspring are born to the ^{423d} guardians, that these should be sent away to other ordinary folk. And if special offspring are born to ordinary folk, these should be sent away to the guardians. And this is intended to show that even in the case of the other citizens, whatever anyone is suited to by nature is the task each should attend to, one person to one particular task, so that each, by practising the one task that is his own, would become not many but one, and in this way then the entire city would naturally come to be one, rather than many." "Yes," said he, "that is a more insignificant instruction than that other one."

423e

"Adimantus, my good man," said I, "we are not giving them a lot of important instructions as someone might presume. No, they are all quite minor, provided they guard the so-called 'one important thing'. Or should I say sufficient rather than important?" "What is that?" he asked. "Education and

upbringing,” said I. “For if, by being educated, they become reasonable men, they will easily see all of this quite clearly, and anything else we are leaving out at present, including the acquisition of women, marriages and procreation of children. They will see that all these should be conducted, as much as possible, so as to make all things common to friends. “Yes,” said he, “that would be most correct.”

424a

“And, indeed,” said I, “the state, once it is set in motion properly, proceeds like a developing circle. For a worthy upbringing and education that is kept safe produces good natures; and worthy natures in turn, by acquiring an education of this sort, become even better than their predecessors in general, and especially in their breeding, as is the case with other creatures.” “Quite likely,” said he.

424b

“So, to put it briefly, those who are to care for the city must hold fast to education so that it does not get corrupted without them noticing. They should, rather, guard this against everything, against any innovation in gymnastics or in music, contrary to our direction. They should be on their guard, as best they can, when anyone says that *People, surely, always give more applause to that song / which is the latest to circulate among the listeners*⁷⁶ for fear someone might presume the poet is perhaps speaking not of new songs, but of a new manner of singing, and is praising this. This sort of thing should not be praised, nor should the poet be ^{424c} understood in this way. Indeed, one must be cautious about change to a new form of music, as it poses a threat to the whole, since the manners of music do not change without the most important civic laws changing too. So says Damon, and I trust him.” “Well, you can count me as someone who trusts him too,” said Adimantus. “Then,” said I, “it is here in music, it seems, that the guardians must found their citadel.” “This, at any rate,” said he, “is where lawlessness easily creeps

in unawares.” “Yes,” said I, “since it is regarded as a sort of amusement that does not do any harm.”

424d

“Nor indeed does it do so,” said he, “except by establishing itself little by little. It flows gently into habits and behaviour, and from these it emerges larger, and enters the arrangements between the citizens, and then from these private arrangements it assails the laws and constitution with unrestrained licentiousness, Socrates, until finally it overturns everything, private as well as public.” “Indeed,” said I, “is that what it does?” “I think so,” said he.

424e

“In that case, as we were saying initially, should not our own children be involved straightaway in play that adheres to law, since if play itself becomes lawless and the children do likewise, it is impossible that they would develop into law abiding men?” “Yes, how could they?” said he.

425a

“Well then, when the children, having made a good start at playing, adopt a lawful spirit through music, then, in contrast to those other cases, this accompanies them in everything, and develops them, setting right anything in the city that was previously cast down.” “True indeed,” said he. “Then these people discover for themselves,” said I, “the seemingly trivial regulations, all of which their predecessors subverted.” “What sort of regulations?”

425b

“This sort: appropriate silence of the young in the presence of their elders, for instance; offering them seats, and standing up before them; care of parents; hairstyles, clothes, shoes, and physical appearance in general, and anything else of that sort. Do you not think so?” “I do.” “But to institute laws for these is, I think, silly. For having been instituted as laws, verbal or written, they are surely not acted upon, nor do they last.” “No,

how could they?"

425c

"It is likely at any rate, Adimantus," said I, "that the direction set by their education determines the sort of things that follow thereafter. Or does like not always call forth like?" "Of course." "And finally, then, I believe we would declare that it turns into something single, complete and active, which is either good, or the opposite." "Inevitably," he said. "That," said I, "is why I, for one, would not go further and attempt to institute laws for this sort of thing." "Well, that is reasonable," said he.

425d

"But, by the gods," said I, "what about commercial affairs and all the arrangements with one another that people enter into in the market, and, if you like, the contracts with manual labourers, actions for slander or assault, the bringing of lawsuits, the appointment of jurors, and if necessary, I presume, the imposition and payment of commercial or maritime taxes, general regulations of the market, the city, and the harbours, and anything else like this. Shall we bring ourselves to institute laws for any of these?"

425e

"No," said he, "it is not worth giving instructions to men who are noble and good, since in most of these cases in which laws need to be instituted, they will, I presume, easily discover them." "Yes, my friend," said I, "provided god grants them preservation of the laws we described before." "If not," said he, "they will spend their lives continually instituting and amending a whole host of regulations of this sort, in the belief that they will arrive at the best arrangement." "You are saying," said I, "that people like this are living like sick people who are not prepared to depart from their degenerate lifestyle because they lack the restraint required to do so." "Entirely so."

426a

“And, indeed, these people live their lives in a delightful manner. For in spite of any medical treatment, they make no progress, although they do make the diseases more complicated and more extensive, and they are always hoping, whenever anyone suggests a remedy, that this is the one that will make them healthy.” “Yes,” said he, “that is exactly the sort of thing that happens to people who are sick in this way.”

426b

“What about this?” I said. “Is it not a delightful feature of these people that what they regard above all as their greatest enemy is the person who speaks the truth, namely that until one gives up drunkenness, gluttony, womanising and laziness, neither drugs nor burning nor cutting, nor indeed any charms or amulets, nor anything else of that sort, will be of any benefit at all?”

426c

“It is not really delightful,” said he, “since getting annoyed with someone who speaks well holds no delight.” “It seems,” said I, “that you are not an admirer of men like this.” “No indeed, by Zeus.” “In that case, you will not praise the city as a whole either, as we said before, if it acts in this way. Or does it not seem to you that those cities that are badly governed and yet direct their citizens not to change the existing state of affairs as a whole, on pain of execution for doing so, are behaving just like those sick people? And whoever is pleased to serve them even though they are governed in this way, who delights them with flattery, who anticipates their wishes and is clever at fulfilling them, he will be their good man, wise too in important matters, and will win their respect.”

426d

“Yes,” said he. “I think they are behaving in the same way, and I have no praise whatsoever for them either.” “And what about those who are willing to serve cities like these, and are eager to do so? Are you not delighted by their courage and humanity?”

"I am," said he, "except in cases where they are deceived into believing that they are statesmen just because most people praise them." "What are you saying?" said I. "Can you not sympathise with the men? If a man who does not know how to measure is told by people like himself that he is six-foot tall, do you think it is possible for him not to believe this about himself?" "No, again I do not think so," said he.

426e

"Then, do not be so harsh with them. For people like this are the most delightful of all, instituting laws of the sort we just described, amending them, always believing they will find some way of curtailing corrupt practices in business dealings, and in the other areas I spoke of just now, while being unaware that they really are, as it were, cutting off the head of the Hydra."⁷⁷ "Yes, indeed," said he, "that is all they are doing."

427a

"Well, then," said I, "I would not have thought the true legislator needs to trouble himself with this sort of thing in relation to laws or civic affairs, either in a badly governed city or a well-governed one – in the former, because it is of no benefit and achieves nothing, and in the latter, because some of them could be discovered by anyone at all, while the others emerge automatically from the practices described earlier."

427b

"So," he asked, "what would be left for our legislative process?" And I said, "For us there is nothing, but for Apollo, who is in Delphi, there remain the greatest, most beautiful, and primary subjects of legislation." "What are they?" he asked. "The foundation of temples, sacrifices, and general care for gods, daimons and heroes; then, for those who have died, burial rites and whatever services to the denizens of the other world are needed to keep them well disposed. For obviously we have no knowledge of such matters, nor, as we are founding our city, shall we believe anyone else if we have any sense, nor shall we

have recourse to any ^{427c} interpreter except our ancestral one. For this god is surely the ancestral interpreter for all humanity in such matters, seated on the navel stone in the middle of the earth, giving his interpretations.”⁷⁸ “Yes, you are expressing that nicely,” said he, “and that is how it should be done.” “Well, then,” said I, “although your city would be founded at this stage, dear son of Ariston, you should now proceed to look within it, provided with sufficient light from somewhere. Do this yourself, and call upon your brother and Polemarchus and the others, in case we may somehow see ^{427d} what precisely justice may be, and injustice too I suppose, and what the difference between them is, and which of them a man who is to be happy should acquire, whether all gods and men are aware of this or not.”

^{427e}

“You are talking nonsense,” said Glaucon, “since you promised that you yourself were going to search for this because it would be an unholy act on your part not to come to the aid of justice, to the best of your ability, in every possible way.” “True,” said I. “You have reminded me and I should act accordingly, but you should all be involved too.” “That is what we shall do then,” said he.

^{428a}

“Well,” said I, “I hope we shall find it in the following way. I think our city, if it has indeed been founded correctly, is perfectly good.” “It must be,” said he. “Then it is obvious that it is wise, courageous, sound-minded and just.” “Obviously.” “Is it not the case that if we can find some of these qualities in the city, the remainder will be what has not been found? “Of course.” “Well, suppose there were four different things, and we were looking for one of them in something or other, and we then recognised this one first, that would be enough for us. But if we had previously recognised the other three, by this fact alone the object of our search would be recognised too, since obviously it is just the remainder and nothing else.” “Correct,”

said he. "So, in relation to these excellences, since there are four of them,⁷⁹ should we not conduct our search in the same way?" "Obviously."

428b

"And, indeed, it seems to me that wisdom is the first thing that is seen plainly in this, and something unusual becomes evident about it." "What?" he asked. "The city we have described is, I think, actually wise, since it is well advised, is it not?" "Yes." "And, indeed, it is obvious that being well advised is, in itself, knowledge of some sort. For it is not by ignorance, but by knowledge, that people are well advised." "Clearly." "But there are many varieties of knowledge in the city." "Yes, there must be." "Now, is it because of the knowledge of its carpenters that a city should be referred to as wise and well advised?"

428c

"Not at all," said he. "Because of this knowledge it is referred to as knowledgeable in carpentry." "So, it is not because of the knowledge dealing with wooden implements, and advising on how they might turn out best, that a city should be called wise." "No, indeed." "What about the knowledge dealing with objects made from bronze, or any other knowledge of this sort?" "It is not any of these either," said he.

428d

"Nor is it the knowledge dealing with producing crops from the earth. Rather, because of this it is knowledgeable in farming." "I think so." "What about this?" said I. "Is there, in the city we have just founded, any knowledge that is particularly associated with some citizens, knowledge by which the city is advised, not about some aspect of its affairs but about the city as a whole, and the manner in which it might best conduct itself towards itself and towards the other cities?" "There is, indeed." "What is it?" I asked. "And in which citizens does it reside?" "It is guardianship," said he. "And it resides in those who rule, to whom we have just given the name perfect guardians." "So,

what, on account of this knowledge, do you call the city?" "Well advised," said he, "and truly wise."

428e

"Now," said I, "in our city, do you think there will be more bronze workers or more of these true guardians?" "Far more bronze workers," said he. "Indeed," said I, "and among those who have some knowledge, and are named accordingly, would not these guardians be the fewest in number of them all?" "The fewest by far." "So, a city founded on a natural basis would be wholly wise because of the smallest group or part of itself and the knowledge residing in this presiding, ruling part. And it seems that this class naturally turns out to be the fewest in number, and is the class that deserves to be allocated this knowledge, which alone, among all other kinds of knowledge, merits the name wisdom." "Very true," said he.

429a

"Well then, I do not know how, but we have found this one, one of the four, and where it is situated in the city." "Well," said he, "in my opinion at any rate, it has been discovered quite satisfactorily." "Then again, it is not difficult to discern courage itself, and the part of our city in which it resides, on account of which the city is then called courageous." "How so?" "Who," said I, "could say that a city is cowardly or courageous, unless he had looked to the particular part that fights for her, and goes to war on her behalf?" "No one," said he, "would look to anything else." "Indeed," said I, "the fact that the other citizens in the city were cowardly or courageous would not, I believe, determine whether the city has the one quality or the other." "It would not."

429b

"And so, a city is courageous by some part of itself because it has a capacity of this sort in that part, a capacity which, in any situation, preserves the opinion about what things should be feared, and these are the same things, and the same sorts of

things, that the legislators proclaimed whilst educating them. Do you not refer to this as courage?" "I do not fully understand what you are saying," said he. "Please say it once more."

429c

"I am saying," said I, "that courage is a sort of preservation." "What sort of preservation is it?" "The preservation of the opinion, produced by law, through education, about what should be feared and what sorts of things they are. And when I said 'in any situation', I meant that the brave man preserves this opinion, faithfully, in the face of pleasure or pain, desire or fear, and never rejects it. I can give you what I regard as an example to illustrate this if you wish." "Yes, I do."

429d

"Do you not know," said I, "that when dyers want to dye wool so that it becomes purple, they first make a selection from all these colours and pick one kind – wools that are naturally white – and they prepare these in advance by treating them extensively so that they will take on the colour as best they can, and they then proceed with the dyeing? And whatever is dyed in this manner becomes ^{429e} colourfast, and no washing, either with detergents or without them, is able to remove the colour. Otherwise, well, you know the sort of things that happen when someone dyes wool of other colours, or even dyes these white wools without preparing them in advance." "I know," said he, "that they become washed-out and they look ridiculous."

430a

"Then," said I, "you should understand that we, to the best of our ability, were also engaged in a process of this sort when we were selecting our warriors and educating them in music and gymnastics. Understand that there was only one objective: that once they had been persuaded, as beautifully as possible, by ourselves, they would accept the laws like a dye so that their opinion in relation to what should be feared, and in relation to anything else, would become colourfast because they had

acquired a nature and an education that was suitable. Then, these detergents would not ^{430b} wash this dye out of them, despite their formidable dissolving power, pleasure, which is more to be feared for doing this than any soda or lye from Chalaestra; pain too, or fear, or desire, more to be feared than any detergent. Now, a power of this sort – the preservation, in any situation, of right and lawful opinion as to what should be feared and what should not – this I call courage, and this is what I propose unless you have some other suggestion.” “I have nothing else to suggest,” said he, “for I think you regard right opinion concerning these very issues when it arises without education, as is the case with beasts or slaves, as not entirely stable, and you refer to this not as courage but as something else.”

^{430c}

“Very true,” said I. “Then I accept that this is what courage is.” “And, indeed, you should accept it,” said I, “as being civic courage at any rate, and you will then be right to do so. But we shall, if you wish, give a better exposition of this on some other occasion. At the moment we are not looking for courage, but for justice, and for that enquiry, in my opinion, this is sufficient.” “That is fine,” said he.

^{430d}

“Then, there are,” said I, “two remaining qualities that we need to discern in our city, sound-mindedness and, the reason for our entire enquiry, justice.” “Yes, certainly.” “Now, how may we find justice so that we do not have to trouble ourselves about sound-mindedness anymore?” “Well,” said he, “I do not know. Nor do I wish justice to be revealed first if we will not be considering sound-mindedness anymore. But if you wish to gratify me, consider this before justice.” “Yes, indeed,” said I. “It is only right that I should wish to do so.” “Consider it then,” said he.

^{430e}

“Consider it I must,” said I. “And from our present vantage point, it looks more like a concord and harmony than the previous ones.” “How so?” “Presumably,” said I, “sound-mindedness is a kind of order, and a mastery over certain pleasures and desires, as people say when using the expression ‘stronger than oneself’, the manner of which I do not understand. And other expressions of this sort express a trace of this, do they not?” “Yes, absolutely,” said he.

431a

“Is not the phrase ‘stronger than oneself’ quite comical? For whoever is stronger than himself would of course also be weaker than himself, and the weaker be stronger, since the same self is spoken of in all of these cases.” “It must be.”

431b

“But,” said I, “it appears to me that this expression wishes to convey that there is something better, and something worse, associated with the soul of the particular person, and whenever the part in it that is naturally better is master of the worse, this is described as being stronger than oneself, as it is at any rate a term of praise. But whenever, through bad upbringing or company of a certain kind, the better part, which is smaller, is dominated by the sheer size of the worse part, this is censured as blameworthy and is called ‘being weaker than oneself’, and someone in this condition is said to be devoid of restraint.” “Yes, quite likely,” said he.

431c

“Well then, take a look at our new city,” said I, “and you will find one of these conditions in it, for you would be justified in saying that it is, itself, stronger than itself, if indeed we should refer to the city in which the better rules over the worse as sound-minded, and stronger than itself.” “Yes, I am looking,” said he, “and what you are saying is true.” “And indeed, the numerous and variegated desires, pleasures and pains would be found mostly in children, women and household slaves, and in

the majority of so-called ‘free men’ of the lowest order.”
“Entirely so.”

431d

“But the simple and measured desires which are led by reasoning, accompanied by intelligence and right opinion, are found in just a few people, those who are best by nature and those who have received the best education.” “True,” said he. “And do you not see that these are all present in your city and that the desires of the majority, the common folk, are controlled there by the desires and the understanding of the more moderate minority?” “I do,” said he. “So, if any city should be described as stronger than its pleasures and desires, and thus stronger than itself, this one should be so described.” “Yes, entirely so,” said he. “Should it not also be described as sound-minded on the basis of all these?” “Very much so,” said he.

431e

“And what is more, if the same opinion as to who should rule is present among the rulers and subjects in any city, it would indeed be present in ours. Do you not think so?” “Very much so,” said he. “Definitely.” “So, among which of the two groups of citizens would you say that sound-mindedness is present whenever they hold such an opinion, among the rulers or among the ruled?” “Among both, I presume,” said he. “Well, do you see,” said I, “that our prophecy just now, that sound-mindedness resembles a sort of harmony, was quite accurate?” “Why so?”

432a

“Because unlike courage and wisdom, each of which are present in a particular part of the city – thus making it wise in one case and courageous in the other – sound-mindedness operates differently. It really extends through the whole city, through everyone, the weakest and the strongest alike, and those in the middle too, be it in intelligence, strength, numbers or wealth, or

in anything else like this, and it makes them sing the same song. And so we would be quite right to declare this unanimity to be sound-mindedness, a natural concord of the worse and better as to which should rule, either in a city or in a single individual.” “I agree entirely,” said he.

432b

“There it is,” said I. “We have seen these three quite clearly in our city. That is how it seems at any rate. But what about the remaining form? The city would also get a share of excellence through that, so what precisely would it be? For it is, of course, justice that remains.” “Of course.”

432c

“Now is the time, Glaucon, when we, like hunters, should surround the thicket, paying careful attention lest justice escape us, slip away, and be lost from sight. Yes, apparently it is around here somewhere, so look out and make an effort to catch sight of it, and if you see it before I do, then tell me.” “If only I could,” said he. “But it is better if you use me as your follower, as someone who is able to see what is pointed out quite clearly to him. Then you will be treating me fairly.” “Follow then,” said I, “and pray along with me.” “I shall do so,” said he. “Just lead on.”

432d

“And yet,” said I, “it looks as if the terrain is hard to traverse and shadowy. It is dark indeed, and hard to hunt in, but we must proceed nevertheless.” “Yes, we must proceed,” said he. Then I spotted something, and shouted, “Ho, ho, Glaucon! Perhaps we have a trace of it, and so I do not think it will escape us entirely.” “That is good news,” said he. “In fact,” said I, “we are being stupid.” “In what way?”

432e

“All the while, blessed man, it appears to have been rolling about under our feet from the very outset, and yet we did not see it. We are highly comical figures, like people who sometimes

look for something they are already holding in their hands, and we, instead of looking directly at it, were peering off into the distance, and that is probably why it escaped our notice.” “What do you mean?” he asked. “As follows,” said I. “I think that although we have been speaking of justice, and hearing about it all along, we have not understood ourselves, and appreciated that in a way we have been speaking about it.” “For someone who is eager to hear you,” said he, “this prelude is a lengthy one.”

433a

“But do listen,” said I, “in case I have a point. Indeed, in the beginning when we were founding our city, the rule of action that we proposed throughout was, in my opinion, either justice or a form of justice. And we proposed of course, and have said many times since if you recall, that each individual should engage in one activity in the city, the one to which his own nature would naturally be best suited.” “Yes, we have said this.”

433b

“And, indeed, we have heard from many others, and have often said ourselves, that justice is doing what belongs to oneself and not being meddlesome.” “Yes, we said so.” “Then justice, my friend,” said I, “is likely to be this ‘doing what belongs to oneself’, when it occurs in a certain way. Do you know how I come to this conclusion?” “No,” said he. “Please tell me.”

433c

“It seems to me,” said I, “that after considering sound-mindedness, courage and wisdom in the city, this is what is left, and this is what provides the power for all these to come into existence. And once they have come into existence, it ensures their preservation, as long as it is present, since we did maintain that if we were to find the other three, this would be the one left undiscovered.” “Yes, indeed, this must be so,” said he.

433d

“Well now,” said I, “if we had to decide which of these four contributes most to making our city good, it would be difficult to decide whether it is the unanimity of opinion among the rulers and those who are ruled; or the preservation of the opinion, in accordance with law, as to what things should and should not be feared; or the wisdom and guardianship inherent in the military class. Or is this what does most to make the city good, the fact that among children, among women, among ^{433e} slaves and free, among artisans, rulers and subjects, each individual was engaging in the one undertaking that is his own, and was not being meddlesome?” “It would be hard to decide between them of course,” said he. “In that case, it seems that in relation to the excellence of the city, the capacity of each person in it to engage in what belongs to himself is on an equal footing with its wisdom, its sound-mindedness and its courage.” “Very much so,” said he. “So, would you propose that what is on an equal footing with these three, in terms of the excellence of the city, is justice?” “Entirely so.”

^{434a}

“Then you should also consider the following argument too. Will you assign the task of judging legal disputes to those who rule in the city?” “Of course.” “And do they have any other intention in passing judgement besides ensuring that no one gets what belongs to someone else, or is deprived of what belongs to himself?” “Nothing besides this.” “Because this is what is just?” “Yes.” “So, we could also accept on this basis too that having or doing what is one’s own and what belongs to oneself is justice.” “This is so.”

^{434b}

“Then let us see if this seems to you as it does to me. Suppose a carpenter attempts to do the work of a shoemaker, or a shoemaker the work of a carpenter, or they exchange tools or social status with one another, or the same person tries to engage in both activities, and all the other roles are changed

too, do you think this would greatly harm the city?" "Not really," said he.

434c

"But whenever someone, who is by nature a craftsman or some other commercial type, puffed up by wealth, numbers, strength or anything else like this tries to enter the military class, or a member of that class tries to enter the decision-making guardian class undeservedly, and they interchange their instruments and social status with one another, or the same person tries to engage in all these activities at the same time, then I think you agree with me that this exchange of roles and this meddling is the ruination of the city." "Yes, entirely so."

434d

"So, this meddling among these classes, three in number, and changing one into the other, is enormously harmful to the city, and this, above all, may be referred to most correctly as evil-doing." "Exactly so." "And would you not declare that the greatest evil-doing towards one's own city is injustice?" "Of course." "So this is injustice. Then again, we may say that the opposite of this, the commercial, auxiliary and guardian classes, engaging in their own functions, each of them doing what belongs to itself in the city, would be justice and would render the city just." "Yes," said he, "that is it. Just so."

434e

"Let us not," said I, "say it with complete certainty just yet. But if this form, when applied to each person individually, is also accepted by us as justice in that case too, we shall concede the point at that stage. What else could we do? But if not, we shall then consider something else. But we should now complete the enquiry in which we presumed that if we first attempted to observe justice in something large that possesses it, we would more easily discern the sort of thing it is in a single person. Now, we thought this large entity was a city, and so we founded the best one we could, ^{435a} knowing full well that justice would

be present in the good one. “So, we should apply whatever has become evident in the city to the individual, and if it corresponds, all will be well. But if something different becomes evident in the case of the individual, we should go back again to the city and put this to the test. Then perhaps, scrutinising them side by side and rubbing them together, we might cause justice to blaze forth like fire from firesticks, and once it has made its appearance we could become certain of it for ourselves.” “Yes,” said he, “that is the method and we should do as you say.” “Well now,” said I, “if something may be described as the same, be it larger or smaller, would it turn out to be unlike in that way, in the way it is described as the same, or would it be like in that way?” “Like,” said he.

435b

“And in that case,” said I, “a just man will not differ from a just city with respect to the form of justice itself; rather, he will be like it in that respect.” “Like,” said he. “And indeed, a city seemed to be just because of the three kinds of natures present in it, each engaged in what belonged to themselves. Furthermore, it was sound-minded, courageous and wise through certain other characteristics and habits of these same classes.” “True,” said he.

435c

“And so, we shall expect, my friend, on this basis, that the individual, having these same forms in his own soul, because of the same characteristics as those, rightly deserves the same names as the city.” “That is completely inevitable,” said he. “My excellent man,” said I, “we have stumbled into a further ordinary issue concerning the soul, whether it has these three forms within itself or not.” “It does not seem at all ordinary to me,” said he. “In fact, the saying may well be true, Socrates, that what is good is difficult.”

435d

“Apparently so, Glaucon,” said I. “And mark my words, in my opinion we shall never understand this in a precise manner from the sort of methods we are now using in these arguments. For there is another path, longer and more extensive, leading to this. Yet, it may perhaps be done in a manner worthy of what has been said previously, and the previous enquiries.” “Would not that be satisfactory,” said he. “Indeed, that would be enough for me, for the moment at least.” “Yes,” said I. “It will be quite sufficient for me too.” “Then do not flag,” said he. “Just enquire.”

435e

“In that case,” said I, “do we not really have to accept that the same forms and traits in the city are present in each of us? For presumably they did not get there from anywhere else. Indeed, it would be laughable if someone were to believe that the spiritedness in cities does not arise from its private citizens, the ones who actually have this reputation, as the Thracians and Scythians do, and almost ^{436a} anyone else from the northern region; or indeed, the love of learning that someone might attribute mostly to our own region; or the love of money mainly associated with the Phoenicians and the people of Egypt, as some would say.” “Very much,” said he. “This is how matters stand then,” said I, “and it is not difficult to recognise.” “No indeed.”

436b

“The difficulty at this stage concerns whether we enact each of these with the same thing, or with three things, using a different one for each. Do we learn with one of the parts within us, become spirited with another, and then feel desire with some third part, concerned with the pleasures of food and procreation, and anything related to these? Or do we, in each case, act with the whole soul when we are impelled to action? These are the issues that will be difficult to determine properly.”

436c

"I think so too," said he. "Well, there is a way to determine whether these are the same as one another, or different." "How?" "It is obvious that the same thing will not, at the same time, do or suffer opposites, in the same respect and in relation to the same thing, at any rate. And so, if we should somehow find this happening in the case of these three, we shall know that the things in question are not the same, but a number of different things." "So be it." "Then please consider what I am saying." "Speak," said he. "So, is it possible," said I, "for the same thing to be stationary and moving at the same time, in the same respect?" "Not at all."

436d

"But we should agree this even more precisely in case we encounter some conflict as we proceed. For if someone describes a man who is stationary but is moving his hands and his head, and says that the same person is stationary and moving at the same time, I presume we would not think that was the right way to describe this. We would say that a part of him is stationary, while another part is moving. Is this not so?" "Just so."

436e

"Now, if the person saying all this were to enjoy himself even more, by making the subtle point that spinning tops as a whole are stationary and in motion at the same time when they are spinning around, with their centre fixed in the same place, we would not accept this, because in cases like this, they are not at rest and moving about in respect of the same parts of themselves. We would say, rather, that they have straight and circular in them, and in respect of the straight, they are stationary since they are not tilting in any way, while in respect of the circular, they are moving in a circle. But when the straight inclines to the right or the left, to the front or the back, and it is revolving at the same time, then it is not stationary at

all.” “And we would be right to say so,” said he.

437a

“So, no assertions of this sort will bother us or persuade us to any extent, that the same thing could ever experience, be, or perform two opposites at the same time, in the same respect, in relation to the same thing.” “Not me, at any rate,” said he. “Nevertheless,” said I, “so that we are not compelled to drag this out by going through all possible objections of this sort and confirm that they are not true, let us assume that this is how matters stand, and proceed, having agreed that if it ever proves otherwise, all our conclusions derived from this will have been undone.” “Yes,” said he. “That is what we should do.”

437b

“In that case,” said I, “would you propose that assenting and dissenting, striving to get something and rejecting it, embracing and pushing away, everything of this sort, are all opposites of one another, regardless of whether one does them or suffers them? For that I presume makes no difference.” “Yes,” said he. “They are opposites.”

437c

“What about this?” I said. “What about hunger and thirst and the desires in general, wanting and wishing too? Would you not, somehow, include these among those forms we just described? For example, would you not say that the soul of someone who has a desire either strives for whatever it desires or embraces whatever it wishes to obtain? Or again, insofar as it wants something to be provided, would you not say it assents to this, assents to itself, as if someone else was asking, and the soul was reaching out to get it?” “I would.”

437d

“What about not wishing, not wanting and not desiring? Would we not associate these with the soul’s pushing away or driving away from itself, and, in general, the opposites of those previous examples?” “Of course.” “This being the case, shall we

maintain that desires constitute a particular class, and the most obvious of these are what we call thirst and hunger?” “We shall,” said he. “Is not one a desire for drink, the other for food?” “Yes.” “Well then, insofar as it is thirst, would it be a desire in the soul for anything more than this, anything more than what we are saying it is a desire for? Is thirst, for instance, a thirst for hot or cold drink, or a lot of or little drink, or, in short, for a certain kind of drink? Or if some heat is present ^{437e} in addition to the thirst, would it give rise to the desire for cold, and if cold is present, to the desire for hot? And if, because of the presence of ‘much’, the thirst is much, will it bring about a desire for much, and if it is little, a desire for little? Or is it the case that thirst itself will never become a desire for anything else besides what it is naturally for, namely drink, while hunger, for its part, is desire for food?” “That is it,” said he. “Each desire itself, without qualification, is only for the natural object of that desire, just that, while any additions are desires for something of this sort or something of that sort.”

^{438a}

“And beware,” said I, “lest anyone trouble our unreflective minds by saying that no one desires drink or food, but good drink and good food, since everyone of course desires what is good. So if thirst is desire, it would be for good, be it good drink or anything else. And the same holds for the other desires.” “Yes,” said he. “Perhaps someone who said this might seem to have a point.”

^{438b}

“Well now,” said I, “in the case of the sort of things that are related to something else, the things of a certain kind are related to something else of a certain kind, or so it seems to me, while the things, just by themselves, relate to themselves alone.” “I do not understand,” said he. “Do you not understand,” I said, “that the greater is greater in relation to something?” “Entirely so.” “Is it not greater in relation to the lesser?” “Yes.”

“And what is much greater is much greater in relation to what is much less. Is this the case?” “Yes.” “And what is greater, on occasion, is so in relation to what is less, on occasion, and what will be greater will be so in relation to what will be less?” “Of course,” said he.

438c

“And does the same apply to more in relation to fewer, double in relation to half, and everything else of this sort, and of course heavy in relation to light, fast in relation to slow, and hot in relation to cold, and everything like these?” “Very much so.” “What about various kinds of knowledge? Does not the same thing apply? Knowledge is, itself, knowledge of learning, of learning itself, or of whatever we should propose that the object of knowledge actually is. Whereas, particular knowledge of a certain kind is of something particular of a certain kind. What I mean is this. When knowledge of how to build a house arose, was it not ^{438d} different from the other kinds of knowledge so that it could be referred to as ‘house-building knowledge’?” “Of course.” “Was this not by its being a certain kind of knowledge, a kind that is different from any of the others?” “Yes.” “Was it not because it was of something of a certain kind that knowledge itself became knowledge of a certain kind, and does not the same apply to the other skills and kinds of knowledge?” “Just so.”

438e

“Well, then,” said I, “if indeed you understand now, please accept that this is what I wanted to say earlier: that among things that are related to something else, these, just by themselves, relate to these just by themselves, while those of a certain kind relate to things of a certain kind. And I do not mean that they are also the sorts of things they are related to so that knowledge of what is healthy or diseased is healthy or diseased knowledge, and knowledge of what is bad and good is bad or good knowledge. Rather, when knowledge became not just

knowledge of the object of knowledge, but of something of a certain kind, namely health or disease, then the knowledge as a consequence became knowledge of a certain kind and was no longer simply called knowledge. Once the particular kind is added on, it is called medical knowledge.” “I understand,” said he, “and I think this is how matters stand.”

439a

“Well, then,” said I, “in the case of thirst, would you not propose that it is one of those things that is what it is in relation to something else? And what it is, of course, is thirst.” “I would,” said he, “and it is in relation to drink.” “And is it not a particular kind of thirst related to a particular kind of drink, while thirst itself is neither for much nor little, neither for good nor bad, nor in short for any particular kind of drink? Thirst itself is rather, by nature, only for drink itself?” “Entirely so.” “So, the soul of the thirsty person, insofar as it is thirsty, wants to do nothing else except drink. It yearns for this and strives for this.” “Of course.”

439b

“In that case, if anything ever draws it away from drink when it is thirsty, would not that be something else within the soul besides that which is just thirsty, and is leading it on like a wild animal to drink? For according to us, the same thing does not, at the same time, do opposite things with the same part of itself in relation to the same thing.” “Indeed not.” “So, for instance, in the case of an archer, I presume it is not appropriate to say that his hands push and pull the bow at the same time, but that one hand pushes while the other pulls.” “Entirely so,” said he.

439c

“Now, would we maintain that there are, on occasion, people who refuse to drink although they are thirsty?” “Very much so,” said he, “lots of them, on many occasions.” “Well, then,” said I, “what might one say about these people? Whatever bids them drink is present in their soul, is it not? And whatever

forbids them is there too, and this is something different which overpowers whatever bids them.” “I think so,” said he. “Now, does not whatever forbids such actions as these arise, whenever it does arise, from reasoning? While everything that attracts and drags the soul comes about through external influences, or diseases?” “Apparently.”

439d

“So,” said I, “it would not be unreasonable for us to regard these as two things, separate from one another, referring to the one by which the soul reasons as the rational part, and to the one by which ^{439e} it is passionate, hungry, thirsty, or is aroused by the other desires, as the irrational, appetitive part, associated with certain satisfactions and pleasures.” “Indeed,” said he, “it would be reasonable for us to think so.” “Then, we should,” said I, “distinguish these two forms in the soul. But what about spirit, and that by which we become spirited? Is this a third form, or would it be similar in nature to one or the other of these two?” “To one of them, perhaps,” said he. “To the appetitive.”

440a

“But I heard a story once,” said I, “and I believe it, that Leontius, son of Aglaion, was coming up from the Piraeus, along the outside of the northern wall, when he noticed corpses lying beside the public executioner. He felt a desire to look at them, and at the same time he was disgusted and turned himself away, and for a while he struggled and covered his face. But finally, overpowered by the desire, he opened his eyes wide, ran up to the corpses and said, ‘Take a look, you wretches, have your fill of this beautiful sight!’.” “I have heard this myself,” said he. “Well,” said I, “this story indicates that wrath sometimes fights against desires, one thing fighting against another.” “Yes, it does indicate this,” said he.

440b

“Are there not many other situations too where desires are forcing someone to act contrary to reason, and he reviles

himself and rouses his spirit against the part within himself that is forcing him, as if there are two factions, and the spirit of a person like this becomes the ally of the reasoning part. But spirit making common cause with the desires, when reason concludes that something should not be done... I am sure you would say you have never observed anything like this in yourself, nor I presume in anyone else.” “No, by Zeus,” said he.

440c

“But what if someone thinks he himself is acting unjustly?” I asked. “Is it not the case that the more noble he is, the less able he is to get angry because he suffers hunger or cold, or anything else like that, at the hands of someone who believes he is inflicting these justly? Indeed, I am saying that his spirit will not be prepared to rise up against this fellow.” “True,” said he.

440d

“And what if someone believes he is being treated unjustly? In that case, does he not seethe with anger and fight alongside whatever seems just? And despite suffering hunger, cold, and everything of that sort, does he not endure and prevail, never forsaking all that is noble, until he has either succeeded or perished or is called back and calmed by the reason within him, just as a dog is recalled by a shepherd?” “Entirely so,” said he. “It is just as you say. And of course we installed the auxiliaries in our city, just like dogs, obedient to their rulers, the shepherds of the city.” “You have appreciated what I wish to explain quite well,” said I. “But I wonder whether you noticed something else besides this.” “What?”

440e

“That the spirited element is appearing opposite to how it did just recently. Then we thought that it was something appetitive, but now, in total contrast, we are saying that when there is conflict in the soul, it is much more inclined to deploy its weaponry in support of the rational element.” “Entirely so,” said he.

441a

“Now, does it do so as something different from the rational element, or as a form of the rational element, in which case there would not be three elements in the soul but two, the rational and the appetitive? Or is the soul just like the city, which was constituted by three classes, the commercial, the auxiliary and the deliberative? And is the spirited element, therefore, a third thing in the soul, a natural auxiliary to the rational element, unless it gets corrupted by a bad upbringing?”

441b

“It must be a third element,” said he. “Yes,” said I, “provided it is shown to be different from the rational element, just as it was shown to be different from the appetitive element.” “But that is not difficult to show,” said he. “Indeed, even in children, you can see that although they are full of spirit as soon as they are born, some of them, in my opinion, never partake of reason, while most of them take a long time to do so.” “Yes, by Zeus,” said I. “You put that nicely. And even in wild animals it can be seen that what you are saying is true. And in addition to these examples, the extract from Homer that we quoted elsewhere will lend support: *He smote his breast and rebuked his heart with the words...*⁸⁰ since in this case Homer has clearly made the part that has reasoned about what is better and what ^{441c} is worse rebuke the unreasoning spirit, as if they were two different things.” “Exactly,” said he, “you are right.” “So,” said I, “we have, with some difficulty, come safely through all this, and we have agreed that in all likelihood the same kinds are present in the city and in the soul of each individual person, and the same number too.” “This is so.” “Well, is it not necessarily the case, at this stage, that in whichever way the city is wise, so too is the private citizen wise, and the element by which the city is wise is the element by which the person is wise?” “Of course.”

441d

“And is the element by which a private citizen is courageous also the element by which the city is courageous, and is the way in which one is so the way in which the other is so, and in all other cases related to excellence must the same manner of being so apply to both?” “Necessarily.” “Then, Glaucon, I presume we shall maintain that a man is just, in the same way that a city was just.” “This too is necessarily the case.” “But we surely have not forgotten that this city was just, by each of the three classes within it doing what belongs to itself.” “I do not think we have forgotten,” said he.

441e

“Then, we must remember that each of us, in whom each of the parts within us does what belongs to itself, will be just, and will be doing whatever belongs to himself.” “We must remember this, indeed,” said he. “So, is it not appropriate that the rational element rule, since it is wise, and exercises forethought on behalf of the entire soul, while the spirited part should be subordinate, and fight by its side?” “Entirely so.” “In that case, as we were saying, does not the combination of music and gymnastics make them both harmonious, intensifying and nurturing the one with noble words and learning, while relaxing and soothing the other, making it gentle through harmony and rhythm?” “Exactly,” said he.

442a

“And these two, then, nurtured in this way, having learned and been educated in what truly belongs to themselves, will take command of the appetitive element, which is the most extensive part of the soul in each of us, and the part that is by nature the most greedy for wealth. They will watch over this in case it gets too big and strong by filling itself with the so-called pleasures of the body, and rather than doing what belongs to itself, attempts to enslave and rule over what its kind should not rule over, and overturn the entire life of everyone.” “Very much so,” said he.

442b

“And are not these two,” said I, “also best equipped to guard against external enemies, on behalf of the soul and the body too, one giving advice, the other fighting on their behalf following the advice of the ruling element, and carrying it out courageously?” “Just so.”

442c

“And we call each individual courageous too – I presume, because of this – whenever his spirited element, in the face of pain or pleasure, holds to what has been proclaimed by the words to be worthy of fear, or not.” “And rightly so,” said he. “And we call him wise because of that small part, the one that ruled in him and made these proclamations; a part that has, in turn, the knowledge within itself of what is beneficial to each part and to the whole community, consisting of the three of them.” “Very much so,” said he.

442d

“What about this? Is not being sound-minded the result of the friendship and harmony among these themselves, when the ruling element and the two that are ruled share the belief that the rational element should rule, and do not take a stand against it?” “That”, said he, “is exactly what sound-mindedness is, either in a city or a private citizen.” “Then again, he will be just because of the principle we have referred to on many occasions. He will be just because of this, and in this way.” “Yes, he really must be.”

442e

“Well then, what about this?” said I. “Are we seeing justice any less distinctly? Does it seem to be something different from what it turned out to be in the case of the city?” “It does not seem different to me,” said he. “Indeed,” said I, “in case there is any doubt still lurking in our souls, we could make completely certain of this by applying some commonplace considerations to it.” “Of what sort?”

443a

“Suppose we needed to come to an understanding concerning this city and the man who resembles it in nature and upbringing, and whether such a person would withhold a deposit of gold or silver with which he had been entrusted. Do you think anyone could believe that a man like this would do such a deed, rather than someone who is not like this?” “No one could,” said he. “And would not sacrilege, theft, betrayal of friends in his private life, or betrayal of the city in his public life, be alien to this man?” “Alien.” “Nor indeed would he be unfaithful to his oaths or any other agreements.” “No, how could he be?” “Adultery too, neglect of parents, and disregard for the gods, may be associated with anyone else, but not with a person like this.” “Anyone else indeed,” said he.

443b

“And is it that in all these cases, the explanation is that each of the elements within him does what belongs to itself, in relation to ruling and being ruled?” “There is no other explanation. That is it.” “So, are you still looking for justice? Is it anything else besides this power which produces men of this sort, and cities too?” “By Zeus,” said he, “I am not.”

443c

“So, our dream has finally come to maturity, the suspicion we spoke of that, as soon as we set about founding our city, thanks to some god, we had in all probability stumbled upon the origin and some outline of justice.” “Yes, entirely so.”

443d

“And so, Glaucon, this was, after all, a sort of image of justice – that is why it was useful – the principle that someone who is by nature a shoemaker rightly practises shoemaking and engages in nothing else, while the carpenter engages in carpentry, and the same goes for all the others.” “Apparently so.”

443e

“Now, although justice was, in truth, it seems, something of this sort, it was not anything concerned with the external activity that belongs to a person but with the inner activity that truly concerns himself and what belongs to himself, not permitting each element in himself to engage in activities that are alien to it, nor allowing the kinds that are in the soul to meddle in one another’s functions; rather putting what is his own in place well and truly, ruling over and bringing order to himself, becoming a friend to himself, and harmonising the three elements which are really like the three defining notes of the musical scale, the highest, lowest and middle, and any others that are in between. Having bound all these together from many, he becomes entirely one, sound-minded and harmonious. Then, and only then, does he proceed to act if any action is needed, either in the acquisition of wealth, the care of the body, or indeed in civic affairs or private contracts. In all these activities, whatever preserves and helps to bring about this condition, he regards as a just and noble action and he names it accordingly, and the knowledge that presides over this action he calls wisdom. But whatever action consistently undoes this disposition, he calls unjust, and he calls the opinion that presides over it ignorance.” “What you are saying, Socrates,” said he, “is entirely true.”

444a

“There it is,” said I. “If we were to claim that we had found the just man and the just city, and what justice in them happens to be, I do not think we would seem to be telling an out-and-out lie.” “Indeed not, by Zeus,” said he. “So should we make this claim?” “We should.”

444b

“Let it be so then,” said I, “since we should go on to consider injustice next.” “Obviously.” “Must it not, by contrast, consist in faction among these three elements, a meddlesomeness by which they do what is alien to themselves, one part rising up against the entire soul to rule there when that is not its role, a

part that is naturally suited to slavery enslaving the part that is naturally suited to rule? These, I believe, are the sort of things we will say, and that the confusion of these elements, and their going astray, is injustice, lack of restraint, cowardice and ignorance, and in short, all evil.” “That is exactly what they are,” said he.

444c

“Well, then,” said I, “as for performing unjust actions and being unjust, and performing just actions too, isn’t it clear and obvious at this stage what all of these actually are, since it is clear what injustice and justice are?” “How so?” “Because”, said I, “there is no difference between these two and health and disease, which are to the body as justice and injustice are to the soul.” “In what way?” he asked. “What is healthy presumably produces health, while what is diseased produces disease.” “Yes.” “And does not doing what is just produce justice, while doing what is unjust produces injustice?” “Necessarily.”

444d

“And producing health consists in establishing the elements in the body so that they control and are controlled by one another according to nature, while producing disease consists in establishing them so that they rule and are ruled by one another contrary to nature.” “Yes, that is it.”

444e

“Well,” said I, “would not producing justice, for its part, consist in establishing the elements in the soul so that they control and are controlled by one another according to nature, while producing injustice will consist in establishing them so that they rule and are ruled by one another contrary to nature?” “Exactly,” he replied. “So, excellence, it seems, would be a sort of health, beauty and vigour of the soul, while vice would be a disease, disgrace and weakness.” “Just so.” “Now, is it not the case that noble activities lead to the acquisition of excellence, while disgraceful ones lead to vice?” “Necessarily.”

445a

“Then, what remains for us to consider at this stage, it seems, is whether it is indeed profitable to do what is just, engage in noble actions, and be just, whether such behaviour goes unnoticed or not; or, on the other hand, to act unjustly and be unjust, provided one does not pay a penalty, or become a better person by being punished.” “But Socrates,” said he, “that consideration, as I see it, is already becoming absurd if it implies that life is not worth living when the nature of the body is corrupted, even if the person is surrounded by food and drink of every sort, huge wealth and enormous power, ^{445b} yet implies that life will indeed be worth living when this very nature by which we live is confounded and corrupted, provided the person does as he wishes and avoids anything by which he will banish evils and injustices, and acquire justice and excellence, especially since these have turned out to be as we have described them.” “Absurd, indeed,” said I. “But nevertheless, since we have come far enough to see quite clearly that this is how matters stand, we should not flag at this stage.” “No, by Zeus,” said he. “We should not flag at all, not in the least.”

445c

“Come here, then,” said I, “so that you may behold how many forms this evil has in my opinion, those that are worthy of note at any rate.” “I am following you,” said he. “Just speak.” “Well, then,” said I, “it appears to me from our present viewing point, so to speak, having ascended to this level of argument, that there is one form of excellence, and that the forms of evil are without limit, although there are four of them that are worth mentioning.” “How do you mean?” said he. “There are probably as many types of soul as there are types of government, with a particular form.” “How many?”

445d

“Five types of government,” said I, “and five types of soul.” “Tell me, what types?” “I say,” said I, “that one type of government is

the one we have been describing, although it is given two names. For when one exceptional individual arises among those who rule, it is referred to as kingship, and when there is more than one, as aristocracy.” “True,” said he.

445e

“Well, I am saying,” said I, “that this is one form. For whether one such person or a number arises, they would not alter any laws of the city worth mentioning, provided they have recourse to the upbringing and education we have described.” “Yes, that is most unlikely,” said he.

BOOK V

449a

“Well, a city like this and such a form of government, and a man of this sort too, I call good and right. And if this is indeed right, I call the others bad and wide of the mark in relation to the management of cities and provision for the type of soul of their private citizens. There are four forms of degeneracy in cities.” “What are they?” he asked.⁸¹

449b

And, as I was about to speak of these four in turn, and how in my view they each evolve from one another, Polemarchus, who was seated further from Adimantus, reached out his hand, grabbed his garment from above around the shoulder, drew the man toward him, stretched forward, leaned towards him and said a few things, none of which we could hear except, “Well, shall we let this go,” said he, “or what shall we do?” “Not in the least,” said Adimantus, speaking loudly at this stage. “And,” I said, “what precisely are you ‘not letting go’?” “You,” said he.

449c

“Because of what, precisely?” said I. “We think,” said he, “that you are taking the easy way and cheating us out of a whole section of the argument, an important one at that, so that you

do not have to go through it in detail. And you think you will get away with saying glibly that, of course, in the case of women and children, it is obvious to everyone that ‘friends will have all things in common’.” “Is that not right, Adimantus?” said I.

449d

“Yes,” said he. “But ‘right’, like everything else, requires explanation – common in what sense? Indeed, it could be meant in many ways. So do not just pass on. Tell us what sense you intend, since we have been waiting for some time, expecting you somehow to mention the procreation of children – how this will happen and how they will be reared once they have been born – and explain this whole issue of women and children being in common that you are speaking of. For we believe that arranging this correctly or incorrectly is of enormous significance, on the whole, to a system of government. So now, since you are in the process of tackling another form of government before dealing properly with these 450a issues, we are resolved, as you heard, not to let you proceed until you have gone through all these details, just as you did with the others.” “And you can include me in that vote too,” said Glaucon. “Indeed, Socrates,” said Thrasyarchus, “you may regard this as a resolution of us all.” “What have you done,” said I, “tackling me like this? What an enormous argument you are setting in train. It is like starting all over again from the beginning about the form of government when I was pleased that this had been dealt with already, being satisfied if someone would allow all 450b this and accept what was said at the time. Now, when you call these matters into question, you do not realise what a swarm of arguments you are stirring up. I saw this earlier, and I passed on for fear of raising too much difficulty.”

450c

“What is this?” said Thrasyarchus. “Do you think these people have come here on some gold-rush, and not to hear arguments?” “Yes,” said I, “arguments, in measure.” “Yes,

Socrates,” said Glaucon. “But for reasonable people, their whole life hearing arguments like these is the measure. But do not be concerned about us, and, for your own part, do not tire at all of expanding upon your views about what will be the manner of this sharing of children and of women among our guardians, and the rearing of the young ones in the intervening years after they are born and before their education. A troublesome period, it seems. So, try to describe the manner in which this should happen.”

450d

“Blessed man,” said I, “this is not easy to explain since it involves a great deal that is difficult to accept, even more than what we dealt with previously. Indeed, it may be hard to believe that what is said is possible, and even if it were somehow or other to become a reality, it may be hard to accept that these would be the best arrangements. That is why, dear friend, there is some reluctance to touch them at all in case the argument looks like a vain hope.” “Let there be no hesitation,” said he, “for your hearers will be neither unsympathetic nor incredulous nor negative.” “And,” I said, “best of men, I presume you wish to encourage me by saying this?” “I do,” said he.

450e

“Well, you are doing the exact opposite,” said I. “If I believed I knew what I was talking about, your encouragement would be well placed. For to speak the truth when you know it, among reasonable people and friends, on matters of great importance that are dear to your heart, is safe and encouraging. But to construct arguments when you are still in doubt and still seeking, which is what I am doing, is a frightening and perilous undertaking. Not for fear of being laughed at – that is a trivial concern – but that I shall stumble from the truth and bring down not just myself but my friends too on issues we should not stumble from at all. And I prostrate myself before Adrasteia,⁸²

Glaucou, for what I am about to say. For I expect that it is a lesser error to become a murderer by mistake than to deceive noble and good people about what is just and lawful. Now, it is better to run this risk among enemies rather than friends, so you do well to encourage me.”

451a

Glaucou laughed and said, “But, Socrates, if we experience any disquiet over your argument, we shall acquit you as if you had been charged with murder. To us you are pure and not a deceiver, so take heart and speak.” “Well, then,” said I, “according to the law, someone acquitted in court is pure so that is likely to be so in this situation too.” “Then speak,” said he, “now that this is resolved.”

451b

“In that case,” said I, “we need to go back over this once more, and say now, in due order, whatever we probably should have said at the time. And perhaps this would be the correct way: after the male drama has been described thoroughly, let us go on and conclude the female drama, especially since that is what you are asking me to do. Indeed, in my opinion, for people whose nature and education is as we have described it, there is not another correct way of possessing and dealing with children and women besides proceeding in the direction in which we first sent them. In our account we attempted, I believe, to establish the men as guardians of a herd.” “Yes.”

451c

“Well, let us follow this up by assigning them the relevant birth and upbringing, and consider whether that is appropriate for our purposes or not.”

451d

“In what way?” said he. “As follows. Do we think female guard dogs should guard whatever the males guard along with them, and hunt, and share in the other duties too? Or should they be kept at home indoors, unable to do all this because they bear

the puppies and rear them, while the males go out to work and have total responsibility for the flock?" "They should share in everything," said he, "except that we should employ the females as weaker and the males as stronger."

451e

"Now, is it possible," said I, "to employ any creature in the same roles as any other creature if they have not received the same upbringing and education?" "That is not possible." "So, if we are to employ women in the same roles as men, they also should be taught the same things."

452a

"Yes." "Music and gymnastics were given to the men." "Yes." "In that case, these two skills should be given to the women too, along with anything related to warfare, and they should be employed in the same ways." "That is likely," said he, "from what you are saying." "Perhaps, then," said I, "compared to what we are used to, a lot of what we are now describing might appear comical, if practised in the way it is being described." "Very much so," said he.

452b

"What," said I, "do you regard as the most comical aspect of all this? Or is it, of course, the prospect of the women exercising naked in the Palaestra alongside the men, not just the young women but the older ones too, just like the old men in the gymnasium when they are wrinkled and not a pleasant sight, who love their gymnastics nevertheless?" "Yes, by Zeus," said he. "that would look comical, by present-day standards at least."

452c

"Well," said I, "since our discussion is under way, we should not be afraid of whatever jokes, of whatever kind, the witty folk might make about such a transformation taking place in the realms of gymnastics or music, especially in relation to women bearing arms or riding horses." "Quite right," said he. "And

since we have begun to discuss this, we should proceed to the rough terrain of the law, and implore these wits not to do what belongs to themselves but to be serious, and we shall remind them that it is not long since the Greeks thought it disgraceful, and comical too, as do most other races today, for men to be seen naked. And when the practice of exercising naked first started ^{452d} among the Cretans, and then among the Spartans, the polite folk of that era got away with making a mockery of all this. Do you not think so?" "I do." "However, I think once it became evident to those who adopted the practice that it is better to undress for any activities of this sort rather than covering up, then what is comical to the eyes vanished in the face of what reason proclaimed to be best. And this demonstrated that it is futile to regard anything as comical, except what is bad. And that someone who tries to raise a laugh by ^{452e} regarding any other spectacle, apart from stupidity and evil, as comical, will also in all seriousness be setting up another standard of nobility, apart from what is good." "Entirely so," said he. "Well now, should we not first come to agreement on whether all this is possible or not, and grant a right of reply in case someone wishes to argue, in jest or seriously, over whether human nature, ^{453a} in the case of the female, is able to share in all the tasks of the male, or in none of them, or in some but not in others, and over which of these two categories this military role belongs to? Would this not be the best way to start the process, to ensure that we are likely to finish in the best way too?" "Very much so," said he.

^{453b}

"In that case," said I, "would you like us to take up the dispute ourselves on their behalf in case the arguments of the other side go undefended against our repeated attacks?" "There is no reason not to," said he. "Then, let us say on their behalf, 'Socrates and Glaucon, there is no need for you to dispute with anyone else since you yourselves, when you began founding this

city of yours, agreed that each individual should engage in the one function that is his own by nature.” “I believe we agreed this. Why would we not?” “Must there not be an enormous difference in nature between a woman and a man?” “Yes, they must be different.”

453c

“In that case, is it not appropriate to assign a different function to each, the one that is their own by nature?” “Of course.” “So how can you avoid falling into error now, and saying the opposite of what you yourselves said before by maintaining that although men and women are vastly different in nature, they should perform the same functions?” Well, my wonderful friend, what defence will you be able to offer in response to this?” “It is not very easy,” said he, “to respond so suddenly. But I shall ask you, and I am asking you, to elaborate the case on our behalf, whatever that is.”

453d

“These, dear Glaucon, and many others like them, are the issues that I was afraid of when I foresaw them a while ago, and so I was reluctant to deal with the law concerning the possession and upbringing of women and children.” “It does not seem to be an easy subject to deal with,” said he. “Not at all, by Zeus.” “Indeed not,” said I. “But the fact of the matter is that regardless of whether someone falls into a little bathing pool or the middle of a vast sea, nonetheless he swims.” “Very much so.” “Should we not swim too and attempt to save ourselves from the argument, hoping that some dolphin, or some other more unusual saviour, would pick us up?”⁸³ “Quite likely,” said he.

453e

“Come on, then,” said I. “Let us find some way out of this. Although we agree of course that a different nature should engage in a different activity, and that women and men differ in nature, we are now maintaining that these different natures

should engage in the same activities. Are these the accusations against us?" "Yes, precisely."

454a

"Dear Glaucon," said I, "how noble is the power of the skill of contradiction." "Why?" "Because," said I, "it seems to me that many people fall into this unintentionally, and believe they are not arguing, but engaging in discussion. This is because they are unable to consider what is being said by making distinctions on the basis of forms, so they pursue their opposition to what is being said based just upon a word, employing argumentation rather than dialectic towards one another." "Yes, indeed," said he, "that is what happens to a lot of people. But surely this does not apply to us at the moment?" "It certainly does," said I, "since we are in danger of engaging, unintentionally, in contradiction." "How?"

454b

"On the basis only of the word, we are very vigorously and argumentatively pursuing the point that different natures should have different pursuits, but we did not consider, in any way, what kind of different nature we were distinguishing when we assigned different pursuits to a different nature, and the same to the same." "No indeed," said he. "We did not consider this."

454c

"In that case," said I, "we may, it seems, ask ourselves if the nature of bald men and long-haired men is the same or the opposite. And should we agree that it is opposite, and bald men engage in shoemaking, we would not allow hairy men to do so, and again if hairy men did so, we would not let the others do so." "That would be ridiculous indeed," said he.

454d

"Yes," said I, "but for what reason? Is it not because, at the time, we were not speaking of a nature that was the same or different in every respect? Rather, we were paying attention only to that

form of difference or sameness that applies to the pursuits themselves. We meant, for instance, that a man and a woman with the soul of a physician have the same nature. Do you not think so?" "I do." "But a physician and a builder have a different nature?" "Completely different, I suppose." "Well," said I, "if it turns out that the male sex and the female sex excel at some skill, or in any pursuit, should we not then declare that this should be assigned to them? But if it merely turns out ^{454e} that they differ in that the female bears the offspring while the male begets them, and in this respect alone, then we shall maintain that nothing more has yet been presented that is relevant to what we are saying, about how a woman differs from a man, and we shall go on thinking that our guardians and their women should engage in the same pursuits." "And rightly so," said he.

^{455a}

"Now, after this, should we not ask anyone who says the opposite to explain precisely this to us: in relation to what skill or pursuit, relevant to the condition of our city, is the nature of a woman and a man not the same, but different?" "Well, that is fair enough." "But perhaps someone else might also say what you said a little earlier, that although it is not easy to respond adequately there and then, given time to consider the matter it is not difficult." "Yes, they might say that."

^{455b}

"So, do you want us to ask the person who raises such objections as these to follow us in case we may somehow demonstrate to him that there is no pursuit, related to the administration of a city, that is particular to a woman?" "Entirely so." "'Come on, then,' we will say to him, 'answer us. In what way do you mean that one person has a natural gift for something while another person does not? Is it that one person learns it easily while the other has difficulty? Would the one, with minimal instruction, discover a lot for himself about the subject he has been taught while the other, despite a great deal

of instruction and study, ^{455c} would not even retain what he has been taught? And is whatever belongs to the body adequately subservient to thought in one case and opposed to it in the other? Are these the criteria by which you distinguish the naturally gifted person from the one who is not, or are there others?" "No one," said he, "will maintain there are others."

^{455d}

"Now, do you know anything that is practised by humanity in which the male sex does not excel over the female, in all these respects? Or are we to go on at length about weaving and attending to pancakes and stews, in which the female sex does have a reputation, and where it is utterly laughable for them to lose out to a man?" "That is true," said he. "You could say that one sex is much surpassed by the other in every- ^{455e} thing, and although many women are better than many men in many respects, the situation is, on the whole, as you describe it." "So, my friend, in the case of those who manage a city, there is no pursuit that belongs to a woman because she is a woman, or to a man because he is a man. The natures are distributed in like manner among both creatures, and a woman by nature shares in all the pursuits, and so does a man, although a woman is weaker than a man in every case." "Entirely so."

^{456a}

"Well then, shall we allocate them all to the men and none to the women?" "How could we?" "On the contrary, we shall maintain, I presume, that one woman is by nature inclined to be a physician while another is not, one is musical while another is unmusical." "Of course." "Is not one woman inclined towards gymnastics and warfare, while another has an aversion to warfare and is no lover of gymnastics?" "Yes, I think so." "What about this? Will one be a lover of wisdom while another hates it? Will one be spirited while another is devoid of it?" "This is the case too."

^{456b}

“So one woman also has the qualities of a guardian while another does not, since this was the sort of nature we selected in the case of our male guardians too, was it not?” “This sort, indeed.” “So in the guardianship of a city, the nature of a man and of a woman is the same, except insofar as one is weaker and the other stronger.” “Apparently.”

456c

“In that case, women of this sort should be selected to live with and exercise guardianship with men of this sort, if they are indeed up to the task and akin to them in nature.” “Entirely so.” “And should not the same pursuits be allocated to the same natures?” “The same.” “So after all that, we have come back to our previous considerations, and we accept that it is not contrary to nature to prescribe music and gymnastics to our women guardians.” “Entirely so.”

456d

“In that case we were not passing impossible laws, like vain hopes, since we proposed a law in accordance with nature. Rather, our present-day practices that run counter to this are, it seems, more opposed to nature.” “So it seems.” “Was not our enquiry concerned with whether our proposals might be possible, and for the best?” “It was indeed.” “And have we agreed that they are actually possible?” “Yes.” “Then do we need to agree next that they are for the best?” “Of course.” “Well, when it comes to creating a woman guardian, we will not need one education to produce the men and a different one to produce the women, will we, especially since it is taking charge of the same nature?” “No, not a different one.” “Now, what view do you hold on the following issue?” “What issue?”

456e

“Do you presume that some men are better while others are worse? Or do you think they are all alike?” “Not at all.” “Now, in the city we were founding, who do you think turned out to be our better men, the guardians who received the education we

described, or the shoemakers who have been educated in shoemaking?” “What a funny question to ask,” said he. “I understand,” said I. “And what about the other citizens? Are not these guardians the best of them?” “Very much so.” “And what about these guardian women? Will they not be the best of the women?” “This is also the case,” said he. “Very much so.” “And is there anything better for a city than the presence of the very best women and men?” “There is not.”

457a

“And will music and gymnastics, applied in the way we have described them, bring this about?” “Of course.” “So, not only is the regulation we proposed possible, but it is also best for the city.” “Quite so.” “Then, the women guardians must undress, since they will be clothed in excellence rather than garments. And they must share the military role and the other duties of a guardian of the city, and not engage in anything else, although in the exercise of these the lighter duties should be assigned ^{457b} to the women, rather than the men, because of the weakness of their sex. But the man who laughs at naked women exercising with the best of intentions, ‘plucks the fruit of laughter, unmatured by wisdom’,⁸⁴ and does not know what he is laughing at, it seems, or even what he is doing. Indeed, this is surely expressed most beautifully, and always will be, by the saying ‘what is beneficial is beautiful, and what is harmful is ugly’.” “Entirely so.”

457c

“May we then claim that we are escaping this first wave, so to speak, without being swept away completely by describing the law relating to women’s affairs? We proposed that our male and female guardians should share in all pursuits, but does the argument somehow or other agree with itself, since it describes what is possible, and beneficial too?” “Yes, indeed,” said he. “It is no small wave that we are escaping.” “You will not say that this one is big,” said I, “when you see the next one.” “Keep

talking,” said he. “Let us see.” “There is, in my opinion,” said I, “a law that follows from this, and from whatever else has been said before.” “What is it?”

457d

“These women are all shared among all these men, and no woman is to live together in private with any man. And the children too are shared, and no parent is to know its own offspring, or any child its parent.” “This,” said he, “presents a much greater credibility issue than the previous one, in terms of its possibility and also of its benefit.” “I do not think,” said I, “there would be dispute over the benefit, since there is great good, is there not, in women being shared and children too, if it can be done. But I think there would be much dispute over whether this is possible or not.” “Both issues,” said he, “would be disputed, well and truly.”

457e

“You mean,” said I, “that there is an alliance of arguments against me. I thought I had escaped the first one, provided you would accept that the arrangement would be beneficial, and I would then be left with the question of whether it is possible or not.”

458a

“Well, your escape did not go unnoticed,” said he, “so give an account of both.” “Then I must pay the penalty,” said I. “But gratify me to this extent. Allow me a holiday, just as people who are mentally lazy are in the habit of indulging themselves when they proceed on their own. In fact, people like this, before discovering how something they desire will come into existence, somehow set that question aside so that they will not tire themselves out by deliberating over whether it is possible or not. They assume that what they want exists already, and set about arranging everything else, and they delight in working out the sort of things they will do now that this has come into existence, thus making an already lazy soul even lazier.

458b

“Well, I too am getting soft at this stage, and I wish to postpone those issues and investigate how they are possible later on. Just now, on the assumption that they are possible, I shall, if you let me, consider how the rulers will arrange all this in detail once the system is in place, and whether their implementation would be more advantageous than anything else for the city and its guardians. These, if you let me, are the issues I shall first attempt to consider in detail with you. We shall consider those others later.” “I am letting you,” said he. “Go ahead and consider this.”

458c

“Well, I think,” said I, “that if our guardians are to be really worthy of this name, and their auxiliaries likewise, the latter should be willing to follow orders and the former to issue them, in some cases obeying our laws themselves and, in other cases, those in which we transfer responsibility to them, they will imitate our laws when giving their orders.” “Quite likely,” said he.

458d

“Then you, their lawgiver,” said I, “just as you selected the men, should also select the women, to bestow upon them women who are as similar to them in nature as possible. And these people, since they have shared dwelling places and meal tables, and no one possesses anything of this sort privately, will be together. And having mingled with one another in the gymnasium, and throughout their general upbringing, they will necessarily be drawn by innate nature to intercourse with one another. Or do you think this lacks the force of necessity?” “Well, not the necessities of geometry at any rate, but those of love, which are surely more potent at persuading and drawing most people.”

458e

“Very much so,” said I. “But besides all this, Glaucon, to have intercourse, or do anything else at all in a random manner, is

unholy in a city of happy people, and the rulers will not allow it.” “No,” said he, “that would not be just.” “Then it is obvious,” said I, “that we should next make marriages sacred, to the best of our ability, and those that are most beneficial would be sacred.” “Entirely so.”

459a

“Well, in that case, how shall they be most beneficial? Tell me this, Glaucon. I notice that you have dogs for hunting, and quite a number of well-bred birds, at home. Now, by Zeus, have you noticed anything about their unions and their production of offspring?” “What sort of thing?” he asked. “Firstly, although they are all well bred, are there not some that are, or turn out to be, the very best?” “There are.”

459b

“Now, do you breed from all of them in like manner, or are you careful to do so, as much as possible, from the best of them?” “From the best.” “And do you breed from the youngest or from the oldest, or as much as possible from those in their prime?” “From those in their prime.” “And if they are not bred in this way, do you believe your stock of birds and hounds will be much worse?” “I do,” said he. “And in the case of horses and other animals,” I asked, “is the situation any different?” “It would be strange,” said he, “if it were different.”

459c

“Well, well, my dear friend,” said I, “our rulers will need to be at their very best if the situation is the same in the case of the human race.” “But the situation is the same,” said he. “What of it?” “Because they will need to make use of many medicines,” said I. “And presumably, in cases where bodies do not need medicine because they are responsive to a particular lifestyle, we regard even an ordinary physician as sufficient. But whenever it is necessary to make use of medicines, we know that a bolder physician is required.” “That is true. But what are you referring to?”

459d

“To the following,” said I. “It is likely that our rulers will have to resort to falsehood on a large scale, and deception too, for the benefit of their subjects. And we maintained, I believe, that everything of this sort is useful as a form of medicine.” “And rightly so,” said he. “And the fact that it is right turns out to be most significant in the case of marriages and in the production of offspring.” “How so?” “Based upon what has already been agreed, the best should have intercourse with the best, as often as possible, and the worst with the worst as seldom as possible, and the offspring of the former ^{459e} should be reared, while those of the latter should not, if the flock is to be at its pinnacle. And all this should take place without anyone knowing about it except the rulers themselves, if our herd of guardians, for its part, is to be as free of faction as possible.” “Quite right,” said he.

460a

“In that case, should there not be some festivals, instituted by law, at which we shall bring together the brides and the bridegrooms? And should there not be sacrifices too, and should not our poets compose hymns appropriate to the marriages that are taking place? We shall make the rulers responsible for the number of marriages so that they may, as best they can, maintain the population at the same level, taking war, disease, and anything else like this into consideration, and as far as possible neither allow our city to become too big or too small.” “Right,” said he. “Then I think certain ingenious lotteries should be devised so that the ordinary person will blame chance, rather than the rulers, for each union.” “Yes, indeed,” said he.

460b

“And to those young men who are somehow best in war, or I presume in anything else, honours and prizes should be given, and in particular more generous opportunity for intercourse with the women so that as many children as possible may be

begotten by men like these, while affording an excuse for this at the same time.” “Right.” “And any offspring that are born will be taken over by the officials responsible for these matters, who may be men or women or both, since official posts too are presumably shared between women and men.” “Yes.”

460c

“Then, I think, having taken the offspring of the good, they will transfer them into the fold, to special nurses who dwell apart in some precinct of the city, while the offspring of the inferior, or of any of the others that are born with deformities, they will hide away in a secret, undisclosed place as appropriate.” “Yes,” said he, “if the race of guardians is to be kept pure.”

460d

“Would not these officials also take responsibilities for the nursing, bringing the mothers to the fold when they are full of milk, while ensuring by every possible means that none recognises her own child, and providing other women who have milk if ever the mothers do not have enough? They will also be responsible for the mothers themselves so that they do not spend too much time in feeding, and will hand over the sleepless nights and the rest of the hardship to wet-nurses and carers.” “By your account,” said he, “childbearing will be very easy for the women of the guardians.” “As it should be,” said I. “But we should proceed to the next suggestion we made, for we said that the offspring should be bred from parents in their prime.” “True.”

460e

“Now, are you also of the view that for a woman her prime lasts about twenty years and for a man about thirty years?” “Which years?” he asked. “A woman,” said I, “is to bear children for the city beginning from her twentieth year until her fortieth, while a man, once he has passed the age at which he can run most swiftly, begets children for the city until the age of fifty-five.” “Well, in both cases,” said he, “this is the prime of body and of

mind.”

461a

“Now, if those who take to begetting for the community are older or younger than this, we shall maintain that their error is neither holy nor just, as a child has been born to the city who, if this goes unnoticed, will have been born without the sacrifices and prayers offered at every marriage by priests and priestesses, and by all of the city; that better offspring, of greater benefit to the city, may always be born from the good people and from the city’s benefactors. But this child will have been born of darkness, accompanied by a shocking lack of restraint.” “Quite right,” said he.

461b

“And the same law applies,” said I, “if any man, still at the right age to beget children, has a relationship with any women of that age without the ruler bringing them together. For we shall state that he is imposing an illegitimate, unauthorised and unsanctified child upon the city.” “And rightly so,” said he.

461c

“But presumably, once the women and the men have passed the age for reproduction, we shall set them free to form relationships with anyone they wish, except daughter or mother, or the children of daughters, or the mothers of a mother, in the case of men; or in the case of women, a son, a father, or the descendants and ancestors of them. And we shall allow all this only after we have directed them to take particular care that no child sees the light of day if any is conceived. And if any child forces its way into the light, this should be dealt with on the basis that such offspring are not to be reared.”

461d

“Yes, that all sounds quite reasonable,” said he. “But how will they recognise one another’s fathers and daughters, and the other relatives you mentioned?” “They will not,” said I, “not at all. But any offspring born in the tenth month, and indeed the

seventh month, after he became a bridegroom, all these he shall address as his son if they are male and as his daughter if they are female. And they, in turn, shall address these men as their father, and similarly he shall call their offspring his grandchildren. And these, for their part, shall call his age group grandfathers and grandmothers. Those born during the time when their mothers and ^{461e} fathers were begetting children shall call each other brothers and sisters so that, as we were saying just now, they will not have intercourse with one another. But the law will grant that brothers and sisters may dwell together if the lot falls accordingly, and the Pythia adds a favourable response.” “Absolutely correct,” said he.

^{462a}

“Well, Glaucon, this, or something like this, is the sharing of women and children among the guardians of the city. But we should next confirm, from the argument, that this fits in with the rest of our system of government, and is by far the best arrangement. Or how should we proceed?” “In this way, by Zeus,” said he. “Now, is not our first step towards agreement to ask ourselves what precisely we can say is the greatest good for the fabric of our city – a good that the lawgiver should aim at when instituting the laws – and what is the greatest evil? And then investigate whether everything we described in detail just now matches the footprint of the good, and not the footprint of the evil?” “Most of all,” said he.

^{462b}

“Well, do we know any greater evil for a city than that which tears it asunder and makes it many rather than one? And do we know any greater good than that which binds it together and makes it one?” “We do not.” “Does not the sharing of pleasure and pain bind it together whenever, to the greatest extent possible, all the citizens are pleased and pained to the same extent by the same successes or failures?” “Entirely so,” said he. “And do not personal responses on occasions like these break

the city apart, whenever some people are troubled while others are delighted, when the very same things are happening to the city or its inhabitants?"

462c

"Of course." "Now, does not something like this arise because expressions like 'mine' and 'not mine' are not uttered in our city at the same time? And the same applies to the word 'alien'?" "Yes, precisely." "Then the city in which the most people say 'mine' and 'not mine' about the same things, in the same respect, is the best managed city." "Very much so." "Is it also the one that bears the closest resemblance to a single human being? For instance, imagine one of us injures his finger. The entire community, extending from the body to the soul, in a single ^{462d} arrangement under the ruling element, perceives this in itself and all of it experiences the pain together, simultaneously, as a whole, even though only a part suffered the injury. And so we say, accordingly, that the person has pain in his finger. And the same argument applies to any other part of the person at all, whether there is pain because the part suffers or pleasure because it finds relief." "The same, indeed," said he. "And in answer to your question, the best administered city is closest to such an arrangement."

462e

"So, I imagine, when anything good or bad happens to any one of its citizens, a city like this is most inclined to say that the victim is its own, and the entire city will share in the pleasure or the pain." "Necessarily," said he, "if it is well regulated at any rate." "Now would be the time," said I, "for us to revisit our own city and observe therein the principles agreed in the argument, and see if this city embodies them more than any other." "Should we not do so then?" said he.

463a

"Well, what about this? In other cities there are, I presume, rulers and the populace, and they are present in this city of ours

too.” “They are.” “And do all of these people refer to one another as fellow citizens?” “Of course.” “But what else besides fellow citizens do the people in other cities call the rulers?”

463b

“In most cities they call them masters, but in those governed democratically they call them just this, rulers.” “What about the populace in our city? What do they call the rulers, besides fellow citizens?” “Saviours and helpers,” said he. “And what do our rulers call the populace?” “Pay masters who give them sustenance.” “And in the other cities, the rulers call the populace...” “Slaves,” he said. “And what do their rulers call one another?” “Fellow rulers,” said he. “And ours...” “Fellow guardians.”

463c

“Now, can you tell me whether any of the rulers in the other cities can refer to one fellow ruler as kindred and to another as not kindred?” “Very much so.” “Does he not regard the kindred as his own and the non-kindred as not his own, and speak accordingly?” “So he does.” “And what about your guardians? Would any of them be able to regard any of their fellow guardians as non-kindred, or speak of them as such?” “Not at all,” said he, “since in the case of anyone he meets he will think he is meeting a brother or sister, a father or mother, a son or daughter, or their offspring, or their forbears.”

463d

“Excellent,” said I. “But tell me this too. Will your laws merely ordain that they should use these names of kinship, or will you also ordain that they should act in accordance with these names in all their activities. In the case of fathers, should they do whatever the law relating to fathers ordains in terms of respect and care, and the obedience that is due to parents, without which they will not fare well with the gods or their fellow men, because their actions would be neither holy nor just if they were to act in any other way? Shall these proclamations ring

from the very outset in the ears of the children, sung by all of the citizens about the fathers, that anyone might point out to them, and about their other relatives too?"

463e

"These are the ones," said he, "for it would be laughable if the names were to be on their lips without the deeds to back them up." "So, in this city most of all, whenever any one citizen fares well or fares badly, all the citizens together will pronounce the words we used just now and say that 'what is mine fares well', or 'what is mine fares badly'." "Very true," said he.

464a

"And did we not also say that with this belief and these words there came a sharing of pleasures and pains?" "And we were right to say so." "Will not our citizens, most of all, share in the same thing which they will all call 'mine'? And by sharing this in this way, will they not, most of all, have shared pleasure and pain?" "Very much so." "Now, is not the cause of all this, besides the general constitution of the city, the sharing of women and children among the guardians?" "Yes," said he, "much more than anything else."

464b

"And we did agree that this was the greatest good for the city, comparing a well-managed city to a human body in terms of its response to pleasure or pain in a part of itself." "And we were right to agree," said he.

464c

"So, the sharing of children and of women among the auxiliaries has turned out to be the cause of the city's greatest good." "Yes, indeed," said he. "In that case, we are also being consistent with what went before. For we said, I believe, that they should have no private households, or land, or any other possession. They should, rather, receive sustenance from everyone else as their guardians' pay, and should all spend it together if they really are to be guardians." "Yes, precisely," said he.

464d

“So, is it not the case, as I say, that whatever was said before, and is being said now, turns them into true guardians to an even greater extent, and prevents them from tearing the city asunder by using the word ‘mine’, to refer not to the same thing but to something different; one man dragging whatever he is able to acquire on his own off to his own house, while another fellow drags things to a different house, also his own, with a separate wife and children, thus introducing the private pleasures and pains of private persons? Rather, with a single belief concerning what is private, all striving as best they can for the same objective, they have the same experience of pain and pleasure.” “Precisely,” said he.

464e

“What about this? Will not lawsuits and accusations against one another almost vanish from their midst because they have no private property, apart from their body, while everything else is shared? And thus they will be free from any factions that people develop because of the acquisition of wealth, children or family connections.” “Yes,” said he, “they will be free of all that. They really must.” “And, indeed, there would be no justification for legal action for assault or violence among them for we shall presumably maintain that self-defence against people of the same age is noble and just, and impose upon them the requirement to look after their bodies.” “And rightly so,” said he.

465a

“And this law,” said I, “is right in the following way too. If someone was provoked by someone else he might satisfy his rage through a personal encounter of this sort and be less inclined to keep going until there were more serious conflicts.” “Yes, certainly.” “What is more, an older man will be given the task of ruling over and restraining all of the younger ones.” “Of course.”

465b

“And, indeed, a younger person will not, unless the rulers command it, use force against someone older, nor is he likely to strike him, nor, I believe, will he show disrespect in any other way either. For the twin guardians, fear and shame, prevent this. Shame prevents him from laying hands upon a possible parent, and he fears the help others will give to the victim, either as his sons, brothers or fathers.” “Yes, that follows,” said he. “Under these laws then, the men will enjoy great peace towards one another, in every respect.” “Great indeed.” “And in the absence of any conflict among themselves there would be no danger of any faction between them and the rest of the city, or one another.” “No, there would not.”

465c

“I am reluctant to mention the most trivial difficulties, which they will be quit of, because they are so unseemly: the flattery of the rich by the poor, the troubles and pains involved in rearing children, and making money to provide for the needs of the household members by borrowing from some people, failing to repay others, using every possible means to provide resources, that they then ^{465d} hand over to the women and household members to manage. All that they suffer over these matters, and what it is like, is self-evident, and it is ignoble and unworthy of mention.” “Yes, it is evident,” said he, “even to a blind man.” “Quit of all this, our guardians will live a life more blessed than the life of Olympic victors.” “In what way?” “These victors are made happy by a small portion of what those guardians get. For their victory is more beautiful and their popular support is more comprehensive. Indeed, the victory they win is the safety of the entire city, and they are crowned with support and everything else that human life requires, they and their children too. They receive honours from their own city during their lives and are granted a worthy burial when they die.” “Yes, that is all very beautiful,” said he.

465e

“Now,” said I, “do you remember that in our earlier discussions, an argument – I do not know whose – took us to task by maintaining that we were not making our guardians happy, because even though it is possible for them to own everything belonging to their fellow citizens, they have nothing? And I think we said that we would look at this again if it turned out to be the case, but at the moment we are making our guardians into guardians and making our city as happy as possible, without focussing upon one group within the city and working on its happiness.” “I remember,” said he.

466a

“Well then, since the life of our auxiliaries now turns out to be far better and more beautiful than the life of Olympic victors, is there any way it compares to the life of shoemakers, or other artificers, or to the life of farmers?” “I do not think so,” said he.

466b

“In that case, what I said there may rightly be repeated here. If a guardian attempts to attain happiness in a way that makes him a guardian no longer, and if such a measured and stable life – which according to us is the best life – is not enough for him, but some mindless, immature opinion about happiness takes over, it will impel him, because he has the power, to appropriate everything in the city, and he will realise that Hesiod was indeed wise when he said that ‘half is somehow more than the whole’.”⁸⁵ “If he takes my advice,” said he, “he will abide by this life.”

466c

“So do you accept,” said I, “this sharing of the women with the men in relation to education, children, and their guardianship of the rest of the citizens, as we have elaborated it? Whether remaining in the city or going to war, should they guard and hunt together like dogs, and to the best of their ability share everything in every way? And by doing all this, do you accept

that they will be doing what is best and not acting contrary to the nature of the female towards the male, and their natural tendency to share with one another?" "I agree," said he.

466d

"Do we not still have to decide," said I, "if it is possible for this sharing to be engendered among human beings, just as it is among other creatures, and how this is possible?" "You have anticipated the point I was just about to raise," said he. "Indeed, when it comes to warfare," said I, "I presume that the way in which they will do battle is obvious." "How?" he asked. "They will march out together, and, what is more, they will bring their children, the stronger ones, with them to the battle so that like the children of other artificers, they may see the work they will have to engage in when they are grown up. And as well as looking on, they will assist and serve in everything related to the battle and will care for their fathers and mothers. Or have you not ^{466e} noticed what goes on in the various crafts? Potters' children, for instance, spend a long time looking on as assistants, before they ever put their hands to the task itself." "Very much so." "Well, should these people show more care than our guardians in educating their children through experience and observation of what is appropriate to them?" "That would be ridiculous," said he.

467a

"Then again, every creature fights especially well when their own offspring are present." "This is so, Socrates. But if they lose, as is prone to happen in war, there is no small danger that having lost their children as well as themselves, they will also make it impossible for the rest of the city to recover." "True," said I, "but do you think that we should arrange, firstly, that there will be no danger?" "Not at all." "Well then, if there is somehow to be danger, should not this be in a situation where they will be better if they are successful?" "Yes, of course."

467b

“But, do you think it makes little difference whether or not those who are to be military men watch the proceedings of the battlefield when they are children? Is the risk not worth taking?” “No, it does make a difference for the purpose you mention.” “So this must be arranged. The children must be made spectators of warfare, and once their safety is assured, all will be well. Is this so?” “Yes.” “And will not their fathers,” said I, “as far as humanly possible, be knowledgeable people, able to recognise which campaigns are dangerous and which are not?” “Quite likely,” said he.

467c

“So they will bring them on some campaigns and be wary of bringing them on others.” “And rightly so.”

467d

“And, presumably,” said I, “they will not appoint ordinary fellows as their leaders, but those who are competent by age and experience to be guides and tutors.” “Yes, that is appropriate.” “Yes, but as we shall declare, lots of unexpected things also happen to lots of people.” “Very much so.” “Well, in the light of such possibilities, my friend, they should be equipped with wings from earliest childhood so that if the need arises they may take flight and be gone.”

467e

“What do you mean?” he asked. “They should go on horseback,” said I, “from the youngest possible age. And having learned to ride, they should be brought to view the battle mounted on horses, not spirited or warlike animals but those that are most swift-footed and responsive to the rein, since in this way they will have the best view of their own future function, and, should the need arise, they could get away safely, following the lead of their older guides.”

468a

“Yes,” said he. “This sounds right to me.” “And what about the events of the battlefield?” said I. “How should your soldiers

behave towards themselves and towards the enemy? I am looking at this correctly or not?" "Tell me," he said, "in what sense." "Among themselves, someone who deserts his post or throws away his weapons, or does anything else like that through cowardice, should he not be reduced in status to an artificer or farmer?" "Yes, certainly." "And should not someone who is captured alive by the enemy be given to his captors as a gift, for them to use their captive as they wish?"

468b

"Precisely." "But someone who excels and wins fame, do you not think he should first be crowned on campaign by his comrades in arms, youths and children in turn? Or do you not think so?" "I do." "Shall they shake his hand?" "That too." "But this, I suppose you would not accept..." "What?" "That he kisses and is kissed by each." "This most of all," he said. "And I would make an addition to the law that as long as they are involved in this campaign, no one whom he wishes to kiss is allowed to refuse, so that if someone happened to be in love with someone else, male or female, he would also be more eager to carry off the prize for valour."

468c

"Very good," said I. "And we have already said that a good person will have more opportunity for union than the others, and will be selected for such purposes more often than the others so that as many children as possible may be born from a person like this." "Yes, we said that," said he. "And indeed, according to Homer, it is right to honour young folk who are good through arrangements of this sort. For he says that when Ajax had won fame in battle, he was rewarded 'with the choicest cuts of meat',⁸⁶ as this is the appropriate honour for someone in the prime of youth and courage, as it honours him and increases his strength at the same time." "Quite right," said he.

468d

“So,” said I, “we shall be persuaded by Homer on these matters at any rate. And, indeed, during sacrifices and everything of this sort, we shall honour the good people, insofar as they prove themselves to be so, with hymns and whatever we have mentioned just now, and to this we shall add ‘seats of honour, meat, and goblets full to the brim’,⁸⁷ so that we may train these good men and women at the same time as we honour them.” “Excellent,” said he.

468e

“Very well. And in the case of those who die on campaign, should we not first say that someone who wins fame in death belongs to the golden race?” “Most of all.” “And shall we believe Hesiod, that when anyone who belongs to such a race dies, they become ^{469a} *Hallowed spirits dwelling on earth, averters of evil, / Guardians watchful and good of articulate speaking mortals?*⁸⁸ “We shall believe him indeed.” “So, having found out from the god how demi-gods and divine beings should be buried, and what the difference is, shall we bury these men according to the mode and manner he expounds?” “How could we do otherwise?” “And ever after, shall we care for and revere their tombs as though they were the tombs of demi-gods? And should we observe the same customs whenever someone, who is judged to have been exceptionally good whilst alive, dies of old age or in some other way?” “It would be right to do so,” said he.

469b

“What about this? How should our soldiers behave towards the enemy soldiers?” “In what sense?”

469c

“Firstly, concerning enslavement, does it seem right that Greek cities should enslave fellow Greeks? Or should they, as best they can, not even allow another city to do so and accustom them to sparing their fellow Greeks for fear of enslavement by the non-Greek races?” “Sparing them,” said he, “is completely better in every way.” “Then they are not to own a Greek slave

themselves, and they are to advise their fellow Greeks to do likewise.” “Yes, certainly,” said he. “And so in this way, they would turn their attention more towards the non-Greeks and show restraint towards themselves.”

469d

“And what about stripping and despoiling the dead after a victory?” said I. “Besides removing their weapons, is this the right thing to do? Or does it not give cowards an excuse for not engaging with another combatant because they are doing something needful when they are poking about among the dead? Has not many an army already been lost because of this sort of plundering?” “Very much so.” “Does it not seem like a slavish and mercenary act to strip the armour from a corpse? And is it not the mark of an unmanly and petty mind to regard the body of the dead man as the enemy when the real foe has fled, leaving only the instrument with which he fought? Or do you think those who do ^{469e} this are doing anything different from dogs who get angry with the stones that struck them, and do not touch the person throwing them?” “Not in the least,” said he. “So should we abandon the stripping of corpses and hindering the enemy from removing their fallen comrades?” “We should abandon this indeed, by Zeus,” said he.

470a

“Nor indeed shall we carry weapons off to our temples as dedicatory offerings, especially those belonging to our fellow Greeks, if we have any interest in fostering good relations towards them. Rather, we shall be afraid that it might be a defilement to bring this sort of thing from our own kin to a temple, unless, of course, the god says otherwise.” “Quite right,” said he. “And when it comes to ravaging Greek land or the burning of houses, how will your soldiers behave towards their enemies?” “I would like to hear you expressing your opinion on that,” said he.

470b

“Well,” said I, “I do not think they would do either of these. No, they should just deprive them of their annual harvest. Do you want me to tell you why?” “Very much so.” “As I see it, just as we make use of these two words, ‘war’ and ‘faction’, so they are indeed two, being applied to two disputes between two different parties. I mean that the disputant is their own kindred in one case, but alien and foreign in the other case. The hostility of their own is called faction, while the hostility of the alien is called war.” “Yes,” said he. “There is nothing strange in what you are saying.”

470c

“Then decide whether this is strange or not. I maintain that the Greek race, to itself, is its own kindred, but is alien and foreign to the non-Greek race.” “Well said,” he replied. “So, when Greeks do battle against non-Greeks, or non-Greeks against Greeks, we shall maintain that they are at war and are enemies by nature, and we should refer to this hostility as ‘war’. But when Greeks do this sort of thing to Greeks, we shall maintain that although they are friends by ^{470d} nature, the Greek state is sick in this case, and has fallen into faction, and we should refer to such hostility as ‘faction’.” “Yes,” said he, “we should consider it in this way. I agree.” “Then,” said I, “take note that in faction, as it is understood nowadays, wherever something like ^{470e} this arises and a city is divided, and one side devastates the land of the other and burns their homes, such faction is regarded as an abomination, and neither party is thought to have any love for their city or they would not have dared to ravage their nurse and mother. But it does seem reasonable for the victors to deprive the vanquished of their harvest and to bear in mind that they are going to be reconciled, and not be at war forever.” “Yes,” said he, “this way of thinking is much gentler than the other.” “What about this then?” I asked. “Will not the city you are founding be a Greek city?” “It must be,” said he. “In that case, will not the people be good and gentle?”

“Absolutely.” “And will they not love their fellow Greeks, and will they not regard Greece as their own, enjoying the sacred places in common with their fellows?” “Yes, absolutely.”

471a

“In that case, will they regard a dispute with Greeks, their own people, as faction, and not refer to it as war?” “No, indeed.” “And will they conduct the dispute with a view to reconciliation?” “Very much so.” “Then they will correct their adversaries out of goodwill, not punishing them to make slaves of them, or indeed to destroy them, since they are correctors, after all, not enemies.” “Quite so,” said he.

471b

“And so being Greeks, they will not ravage Greece or burn down its homes, nor will they accept that all the people in a particular city are their enemies, men, women and children alike. They will accept, rather, that a few enemies are always responsible for the dispute, and for all these reasons they will not be prepared to ravage their land or pull down their houses, since most of them are their friends. They will, rather, pursue the dispute to the point where those who are responsible are forced into a just response by the suffering of their innocent fellow citizens.” “I agree,” said he, “that our citizens should behave like this towards their Greek opponents, while treating the non-Greeks as the Greeks treat us Greeks nowadays.”

471c

“Shall we set down this law for our guardians, that they neither lay waste to the land nor burn down houses?” “Let us set it down,” said he, “and accept that this is all good, and so is what was said previously. But, Socrates, it seems to me that if someone leaves it to you to speak on such issues, you will never remember the question you pushed aside in order to say all this, namely the question of whether it is ever possible for this civic arrangement to come about, and in what way is it possible at all. I agree that if it were to come about it would be really good for

that city. And I will add what you omitted to say, namely that they would fight ^{471d} best against their enemies since they would be least likely to desert one another because they recognise themselves as brothers, fathers and sons, and use these very names. And if the female sex is to campaign with them, either in the same rank or assigned to the rearguard to strike fear into the enemy and to provide assistance if needed, I know full well that with all this they would be invincible. And I see also all the domestic advantages they would have, which you omitted to mention. Now, you may assume that I agree that there would be all these advantages, and thousands more, if this civic arrangement were to arise, so do not say any more about it. Let us try rather, at this stage, to convince ourselves that this is possible, and how it is possible, and bid farewell to everything else.”

^{471e}

“Well,” I said, “you have made quite a sudden onslaught upon this proposition of mine, without any allowance for my hesitation. For perhaps you do not appreciate that you are bringing a third ^{472a} huge and most troublesome wave upon me when I have barely escaped the first two. Once you see and hear this you will have more sympathy and will understand that my reluctance was reasonable, and so was my fear of recounting such a paradoxical argument and attempting to scrutinise it.”

^{472b}

“The more you go on like this,” he said, “the less likely we are to release you from describing how this civic arrangement could arise. So speak, and do not delay.” “In that case,” I said, “should we first be reminded that we got to this point by enquiring into what justice and injustice are like?” “We should,” he said. “But why do you say this?” “No reason, but if we do find what justice is like, shall we also insist that the just man must not ^{472c} be different at all from justice, and that such a man is like justice in every respect? Or shall we be satisfied if he gets as close as

possible to it and partakes of it to a greater extent than most people?" "Yes," he said. "We shall be satisfied with that." "Then," said I, "we have been seeking justice itself, the sort of thing it is, and the perfectly just man, if there be such a man, and the sort of person he would be if he ever did come into existence to use as a model. The same considerations also apply to injustice and the utterly unjust man. The intention was to look to these standards and apply whatever became evident about their happiness ^{472d} or unhappiness, and be compelled to accept that in our own situation, whoever is most like one of those standards will have the like portion of happiness. However, it was never the intention that we would demonstrate that such persons could come into existence." "Yes, what you say is true," he said. "Now, would you maintain that a painter was not really a good painter if he painted an exquisitely beautiful person as a standard, rendered it in consummate detail, but was unable to demonstrate that such a person could ever come into existence?" "By Zeus, I would not," he replied. "Well then, have we not, so we say, been making a standard in words of a good city?"

^{472e}

"Very much so." "Then, do you maintain that our words lack merit, on account of the fact that we may be unable to demonstrate that the city could be established in the manner in which we have described it?" "I certainly do not," he said. "Then that is the truth of the matter," said I. "But if, for your sake, we must endeavour to demonstrate how exactly and upon what basis this is at all possible, I must ask you again to concede the same points regarding such a demonstration." "What points?"

^{473a}

"Is it possible for anything to be enacted as spoken, or must action by nature involve less truth than speech, in spite of what some people think? Well, do you agree that this is the case or

not?” “I agree,” he said. “In that case, do not force me to prove that the sort of thing we have recounted in words can also come into existence in its entirety in deed. Rather, if we are able to discover how a city that is very close to what we have described might be constituted, you must say that we have found out how
^{473b} this city can come into being, which was the task you set us. Would you be satisfied if that happened? I, for one, would be satisfied.” “And so would I,” he said. “Well then, after this it seems we should try to find, and demonstrate, what precisely is enacted badly in the various cities nowadays so that they are not constituted like ours. Also, what change would bring a city to this manner of civic arrangement, the smallest change possible – ideally just one, otherwise two, or the fewest in number – with the least impact.”

^{473c}

“I entirely agree,” he said.

^{473d}

“Well,” said I, “there is one change that could effect this transformation, and I think we can show this. However, it is not minor or easy, though it is feasible.” “What is it?” said he. “I am now,” said I, “on the verge of what we likened to the most enormous wave. But it must be spoken, even if some wave of hilarity is literally going to deluge me with laughter and ridicule. So pay attention to what I am about to say.” “Speak on,” he said. “Unless philosophers exercise kingly rule in the cities,” said I, “or those whom we now call kings and rulers engage in philosophy with dignity and competence, and political power and philosophy coincide in the same person, while the vast majority, whose natures incline them to pursue one
^{473e} rather than the other, are necessarily excluded from both, the cities will have no rest from their evils, my dear Glaucon, and neither, in my view, will the human race. Nor until then will this civic arrangement, which we have described in words, ever grow to its full potential or see the light of day.

Well, this is what made me reluctant to speak earlier, for I could see this will be directly opposed to popular opinion. For it is hard to see that there is no other way for one to be happy, neither as an individual nor as a society.”

474a

“Well, Socrates,” he said, “you have blurted out an utterance and argument like this, and now that you have said it you should expect a large number of men, no common folk, to rip off their garments, grab the first weapon that comes to their hand, and rush at you, naked, at full stretch, intending unspeakable deeds. If you do not ward them off in argumentation and make your escape, you will pay the penalty of being well and truly ridiculed.” “Are you not the one who is responsible for all this, in my case?” I said. “I am doing the right thing,” he said. “However I shall not desert you, but will defend you by whatever means I can, and I can do this through good will and encouragement. And perhaps I may respond to your questions more reasonably than someone else would. But now that you have such assistance, try to prove to the unbelievers that what you are saying is so.”

474b

“Try I must,” I said, “since you are offering such a significant alliance. Now, if we are going to escape from the men you describe, I think it will be necessary to define for them which philosophers we are speaking of when we dare to maintain that they must rule. Then, once that has become evident, we can conduct our defence by demonstrating that it belongs to these men by nature to engage in philosophy and to lead in the city, while it belongs to the others to have no dealing with philosophy and to follow their leadership.” “Now would be the time to define this,” he said.

474c

“Come on then. You will have to be guided by me here if we are to have any chance of explaining this properly.” “Lead on,” he

said. “Now,” I said, “will it be necessary to remind you, or do you remember already, that anyone who is said to love something must, if the description is correct, show that his affection is total, and he does not love one aspect of that thing while not loving another?” “It seems you will have to remind me,” he said, “for I do not really understand.”

474d

“That response of yours, Glaucon, would be appropriate for another person, but it is hardly appropriate for a man of love to be reminded that all those youths in their prime afflict and stir the amorous lover, and all are deemed worthy of his care and affection. Is this not how you behave towards the fair? If someone is snub-nosed you praise him by calling him charming, and if he is hook-nosed you say he is kingly, while if he is halfway between the two you say his features are perfectly balanced. Those who are dark have a manly aspect, those who are fair are children of gods, and as for the name ‘honey-pale’, who could invent it except a coaxing lover who willingly tolerates a poor complexion, provided it belongs to a pretty youth? And, in short, you invent any excuse at all, and 474e resort to any expression at all, to avoid rejecting those who are in the bloom of youth.” “If you wish to allege that I behave as these lovers do, I shall go along with you for the sake of this discussion,” he replied.

475a

“What about this?” I said. “Do you not see the lovers of wine doing the very same thing, welcoming every sort of wine on any pretext at all?” “Very much so.” “And I am sure you observe that those who love honour, if they cannot command an army, will command a lesser cohort. And if they are not honoured by the important and distinguished people, 475b they will be satisfied with the respect of lesser, more ordinary folk, so consummate is their desire for honour.” “Yes, exactly.” “So, do you agree or disagree that when anyone is said to desire

something, we should say that he desires it all, or one part only and not another?" "All of it," he said. "Therefore, shall we say that the philosopher does not desire one part of wisdom rather than another, but desires it all?" "True."

475c

"Then we shall not say that a person who cannot stand study is a lover of learning or a lover of wisdom, especially if he is young and still lacks the reasoning power to distinguish what is useful from what is not, just as someone who makes difficulties about food is said neither to be hungry nor to want food, and will not be called a food lover but a poor eater." "And we shall be right to say so."

475d

"However, anyone with a ready desire to taste all branches of learning, who enters into study gladly and with an insatiable appetite, may properly be called a lover of wisdom. Is this so?" Glaucon replied, "Then you will have lots of unusual examples of such people. For those who love seeing sights all seem to me, anyway, to be like this because they take a delight in learning. Those who love hearing things are the strangest folk to include among the philosophers, for although they would never willingly engage in serious discussion or devote their time to anything of that sort, they run around all the festivals of Dionysus in the city or the country, as if they had hired out their ears to listen to them all. Now, shall we refer ^{475e} to all these people, and others with knowledge of similar activities, or even the minor crafts, as philosophers?" "Certainly not," I said, "but they are similar to philosophers." And he said, "Whom do you refer to as true philosophers?" "Those who love beholding the truth," I said. "Yes, that is all very well," he said, "but what do you mean by this?" "This would not be at all easy for someone else," said I, "but I do think that you will agree with me here." "About what?"

476a

“That since beauty is the opposite of ugliness, they are two. “How could I disagree?” “Therefore, since they are two, each is one.” “I also agree with this.” “And the same argument applies to just and unjust, good and bad, and to all of the forms. Each itself is one, but since they manifest everywhere in communion with activities, bodies, and with one another, each appears to be multiple.” “What you are saying is correct,” he said. “Well,” I said, “this is how I make the distinction, separating the people you referred to as ‘those ^{476b} who love seeing things’ or ‘those who love skills and are practical’, from those we are now discussing, who are the only ones we may properly refer to as philosophers.” “In what way?” he said. “Presumably,” I said, “those who love hearing things, and seeing things, delight in beautiful sounds and colours and shapes and everything that is fashioned from these, but their mind is unable to behold the nature of beauty itself, and to delight in that.” “Yes,” he said, “that is certainly the case.”

^{476c}

“On the other hand, would not those who can have recourse to beauty itself, and behold it just by itself, be quite rare?” “Very much so.” “Now, do you think that a person is awake or living in a dream if he recognises beautiful objects but does not recognise beauty itself, and cannot follow someone else if he leads him to the knowledge of this? Think about this. Is not dreaming an activity in which someone, either in sleep or whilst awake, thinks that a likeness is not a likeness, but is itself the very object which the likeness resembles?” “Yes, I am inclined to say that a person like that is dreaming,” he said.

^{476d}

“Well then, what about someone who, by contrast, thinks that there is beauty itself and is able to behold it and whatever partakes of it without thinking that that which partakes is beauty itself, or that beauty itself is that which partakes. Do you think this person is awake, or living in a dream?” “He is very

much awake,” he said. “Would we not be right to refer to the mental state of this man as knowledge because he knows, and to the mental state of the other as opinion because he is forming opinions.” “Yes, certainly.”

476e

“Now, what if this fellow, whom we accuse of forming opinions and of not knowing, gets angry with us and argues that we are not speaking the truth? Shall we be able to console him and engage in gentle persuasion whilst concealing the fact that he is not of sound mind?” “You really should try, anyway,” he said. “Come on, then. Let us consider what we shall say to him. Or if you prefer we could put some questions to him, maintaining that if he does know something, nobody will begrudge him that. Rather, we would be delighted to see that he knew something. So tell us this: does someone who knows know something or nothing? Now, you should reply on behalf of this fellow.” “I reply that they know something,” he said.

477a

“Is it something that is or is not?” “Something that is, for how could something that is not be known?” “Well, are we satisfied that no matter how we consider the matter, ‘what entirely is’ is entirely knowable, and ‘what in no way is’ is entirely unknowable?” “We are completely satisfied.” “Very well. But if, in fact, something is characterised in such a way that it both ‘is’ and ‘is not’, would it not lie in between ‘what purely is’ and ‘what in no way is’?” “Yes, in between.” “Therefore, since knowledge is directed towards ‘what is’, and ignorance is necessarily directed to ‘what is not’, we must search for something in between ignorance and knowledge, which is directed to that which lies between ‘what is’ and ‘what is not’, if there happens to be such a thing.” “Yes, certainly.”

477b

“Now, do we say that opinion is something?” “What else could we say?” “And is it a different power from knowledge, or the

same power?" "Different."

477c

"So opinion is directed to one, and knowledge to another, each on the basis of its own power." "Just so." "Is not knowledge naturally directed towards 'what is', to know 'what is' as it is? But before we go on, I think we must make a further distinction." "How?" "Shall we say that powers are a class of things that are, by which we are able to do whatever we can do, and anything else is able to do whatever it can do. So I say for example that seeing and hearing are powers, if you understand what I am trying to explain." "I do understand," he said.

477d

"Well, listen, and I shall tell you my view of them. Indeed, with respect to powers I do not discern any colour or a shape, or anything of this sort, as I do in many other things, features to which I can look in order to distinguish for myself between some objects and others. But in the case of a power, I look only to what it is directed to and what it accomplishes, and on this basis I call each of them a power, and whatever is directed to the same object and accomplishes the same thing, I call the same, while anything that is directed to a different object and accomplishes something different, I refer to as different. How about you? What do you do?" "Just as you do," he said. "At this stage," I said, "I should ask you the question again, my excellent friend. Do you say that knowledge is a power, or in what class do you place it?"

477e

"In this one," he said. "It is the strongest of all powers." "And what about opinion? Shall we assign it to power or to another form?" "To no other form," he said, "for opinion is nothing other than the power by which we are able to form opinions." "Yes, and you did agree a little earlier that knowledge and opinion are not the same." "How could any reasonable person," he replied, "ever suggest that something that does not make

mistakes is the same as something that makes mistakes?"

478a

"Well expressed," I said. "And it is obvious that we agree opinion is different from knowledge." "Yes, different." "So is each of them by nature a different power, directed to something different?" "They must be." "Well, is knowledge directed to 'what is', to know 'what is' as 'it is'?" "Yes." "And we say that opinion forms opinions." "Yes." "Does it not form opinions about the same things that knowledge knows? And will the objects of knowledge and opinion be the same? Or is that impossible?" "According to what we have agreed, that is impossible," he said. "If, in fact, a different ^{478b} power is naturally directed to something different, and opinion and knowledge are both powers and each is different, which is what we are saying, then we cannot accept, based on this, that the object of knowledge and the object of opinion are the same." "Now, if the object of knowledge is 'what is', would not the object of opinion be something other than 'what is'?" "Yes, something other than that." "Well, does it form opinions about 'what is not', or is it impossible even to form an opinion about 'what is not'? Reflect on this. Does not someone who forms an opinion apply the opinion to something? Or again, is it possible to form an opinion which is an opinion about nothing?" "That is impossible." "Rather, the person forming an opinion forms it about some one thing."

478c

"Yes." "However, would it be at all correct to refer to 'what is not' as some one thing? Instead, it should be called nothing." "Entirely so." "Well, did we, by necessity, assign ignorance to 'what is not' and knowledge to 'what is'?" "We did, and rightly so," he said. "So opinions are not formed either about 'what is' or 'what is not'." "They are not." "Then opinion is neither ignorance nor knowledge." "It seems not."

478d

“Well, in that case, is it beyond them, exceeding either knowledge in clarity or ignorance in obscurity?” “It does neither.” “Alternatively,” I said, “does opinion appear to you as darker than knowledge and yet brighter than ignorance?” “Very much so,” he said. “Does it lie within these two extremes?” “Yes.” “So opinion would be in between knowledge and ignorance.” “Yes, exactly.”

478e

“But did we not say earlier that if anything were to prove capable of being and of not being at the same time, it would lie in between ‘what purely is’ and ‘what entirely is not’, and that neither knowledge nor ignorance would be directed towards it, but something, which for its part makes its appearance in between knowledge and ignorance, would be directed towards it?” “Correct.” “But now the power that we call opinion has made its appearance in between these two.” “It has.”

479a

“Then what remains for us to discover, apparently, is something partaking of both being and non-being, which may not properly be called either pure being or pure non-being. Should that be found, we would be right to call it the object of opinion, thus assigning the powers at the extremes to the objects at the extremes, and the powers that lie in between to the objects that lie in between. Is this how we should proceed?” “It is.” “Now that we have established all this, let this good fellow speak to me and give me an answer, this man who thinks there is no such thing as beauty itself, or a form of beauty itself, which is always just the same as it is, even though he does think that there are many beautiful things. He is someone who loves seeing things and cannot endure it if someone says that beauty is one, and so too is justice, and that the same goes for the others. I shall say to him, ‘Best of men, tell me this. Are there any of these numerous beautiful things which will not appear to be ugly? Are there any of the many just actions which will not appear unjust, any

sacred things which will not appear profane?”

479b

“No,” said Glaucon, “they must somehow appear to be both beautiful and ugly, and the same applies to your other instances.” “And what about the many things which are doubles? Do they appear to be halves any less than doubles? “No less.” “And things we say are large or small, light or heavy, will they be called by these names any more than the opposite names?” “Yes,” he said, “each of them always has both names.”

479c

“Then, if anyone says that any of these many things is this, is it no more this, than not this?” “It is like party games involving the double meanings of words,” he replied, “and the children’s riddle about the eunuch striking the bat, in which they also make obscure statements about what it was struck by and what it was sitting upon.⁸⁹ In fact, these too are ambiguous, and none of them is capable of being thought definitely to be, or not to be, either both or neither.” “So, do you know what to do with them,” I said, “or can you put them in any better place than in between being and non-being? Presumably they will not prove to be darker than ‘what is not’, involving more non-being, or brighter than ‘what is’, involving more being.”

479d

“Very true,” he said. “Well, it seems we have found that the numerous conceptions about beauty, or anything else, which most people hold, are somehow rolling about between ‘what is not’ and ‘what purely is’.” “That is what we have found.” “And we agreed previously that if something like this were to turn up, it should be referred to as an object of opinion rather than an object of knowledge. The wandering object is apprehended by the intermediate power.” “We agreed on this.”

479e

“So those who see many beautiful things, without beholding beauty itself, and who are unable to follow someone who is

leading them towards it, who see many just actions, but not justice itself, or anything like that, we shall say that these people form opinions on all these matters, but know nothing about the matters on which they are opining.” “We must,” he said. “And what about those who, by contrast, behold things themselves, things which are always just the same as they are? Do they not know rather than opine?” “This must also be so.”

480a

“And will we not say that these people embrace and love the objects of knowledge, while those others embrace and love the objects of opinion? Or do you not remember? We said that the others love and contemplate beautiful sounds and colours, and the like, but they cannot bear to hear that there is such a thing as beauty itself.” “We remember.” “In that case, would it be offensive to call them lovers of opinion or philodoxical⁹⁰ rather than lovers of wisdom or philosophical? Would they get very angry with us if we referred to them in this way?” “Not if they are persuaded by me anyway,” he said, “for it is not appropriate to be angry at the truth.” “Then should those who embrace what anything actually is be called philosophers, or lovers of wisdom, rather than lovers of opinion?” “Yes, entirely so.”

BOOK VI

484a

“Well then, Glaucon,” I said, “after conducting quite a lengthy enquiry, we have, with some difficulty, discovered those who are philosophers and those who are not.” “Yes,” he said, “perhaps it would not have been easy to shorten it.”

484b

“Apparently not,” I replied. “And yet I still think the discovery would have gone better if we only needed to talk about this topic and we had no need to discuss a host of outstanding issues if we are going to discern the difference between the just and

the unjust life.” “What do we need to discuss after this?” he said. “The next issue in due sequence,” I replied. “What else? Since philosophers can apprehend that which is always the same as it is, while those who cannot do so are not philosophers but wander instead amid multiplicity and variety, which of them should actually be rulers in the city?” “How may we give an adequate response to this question?” he said. “Whichever sort proves capable of guarding the laws and the proceedings of the city are the ones to appoint as guardians,” I replied.

484c

“Quite right,” he said. “Well,” I said, “is it obvious whether it is a blind man or a keen-sighted man who should keep watch over something?” “Of course it is obvious,” he said. “Well then, do these people seem any better than blind men? I mean, are these people blind who are, in truth, deprived of the knowledge of what anything is, who have no evident pattern in their soul and are unable to look towards perfect truth, as a painter looks at a model, always referring ^{484d} to that realm and contemplating it with the utmost precision, and who cannot establish regulations concerning beauty, justice and goodness in this realm, if they are needed, or act as guardian saviours of what is already in place?” “No, by Zeus,” he said. “They are not much different from blind men.” “So, shall we install these men as guardians in preference to those who know what each thing is, and are not lacking in practical experience compared to the others or inferior to them in any other aspect of excellence?” “It would be most strange,” he said, “to choose anyone else if the philosophers, in fact, lacked none of the other qualities. For the particular quality in which they excel is really the most important one of all.”

485a

“Well, should we not explain how the same people will be able to possess these qualities and the other qualities?” “Yes, certainly.” “We said at the beginning of this discussion that it is

necessary to understand their nature first, and I believe that if we come to a satisfactory agreement on this, we shall also agree that the same people can possess both sets of qualities, and these must be the rulers of the city and not anyone else.” “How?”

485b

“Well, let us agree something about the philosophic natures. Let us agree that they always love any learning, which would reveal to them something of that being which always is, and does not wander in subjection to generation and decay.” “We should agree on that.” “And what is more,” I said, “they will love all of it and will not willingly dismiss any part, be it small or large, honourable or dishonourable. They are just like the lovers of honour and the flattering lovers we described earlier.” “What you are saying is correct,” he said.

485c

“Here is something else you should think about. Consider whether people who are going to conform to this description must have an additional characteristic in their nature.” “What sort of characteristic?” “Freedom from falsehood. They will never willingly accept the false; they hate it and love the truth.” “Quite likely,” he said. “Oh it is not merely likely, my friend, but absolutely necessary for someone, who is by nature lovingly disposed to anything, to cherish all that is kindred and related to the beloved.” “You are right,” he said. “Now, could you find anything more closely related to wisdom than truth?” “No, how could you,” he said. “And is it possible for the same nature to be both a lover of wisdom and a lover of falsehood?” “Not at all.” “So, the genuine lover of learning must strive to the utmost for all truth from his youth upwards.” “Entirely so.”

485d

“However, when desires are strongly inclined in a single direction, we surely understand that they are weakened in the other directions, just like a stream which is diverted to a

particular place.” “Of course.” “Now, those who are inclined towards the objects of learning and everything like that would, I believe, be concerned with the pleasure of soul just by itself and would forsake the pleasures of the body, if the person is to be truly a philosopher and not artificially so.” “This must necessarily be so.”

485e

“Indeed, such a man is sound-minded and in no sense a lover of money. In fact, it is not appropriate for him to be involved in the concerns of money and its objects, and its enormous extravagance.” “Quite so.” “Yes, and there is something else you must consider if you are going to distinguish the philosophic nature from the unphilosophic.” “What is it?” “Be on the lookout for any involvement in slavishness. For presumably, petty-mindedness is utterly inimical to the soul, which intends to strive always for the whole and entire, of both the divine and the human.” “Very true,” he said.

486a

“Now, do you think that a mind endowed with magnificence, and a vision of all time and all being, could regard human life as something important?” “Impossible,” he said. “And a man like this will not think that death is something terrible, will he?” “Not in the least.” “Then, it seems a cowardly and slavish nature would have no involvement in true philosophy.” “I do not think so.”

486b

“Then again, is there any way that someone who is well behaved – not a lover of money, or slavish, or boastful, or cowardly – could be unjust or difficult to deal with?” “There is not.” “Well, when you are considering whether a soul is philosophic or not, you will enquire whether he was just and gentle from his youth upwards, or unsociable and wild.” “Yes, indeed.”

486c

“And I think there is one more consideration you should not omit.” “Which is?” “Whether he learns easily or with difficulty. Or do you expect that someone would ever really love an activity when its performance caused him pain, and after much difficulty he accomplished little?” “No, he would not.” “And what if he could preserve nothing of what he learned, being full of forgetfulness? Could he avoid being empty of knowledge?” “No, how could he?” “Now, as his labour accomplishes nothing, do you not imagine he will be driven finally to hate both himself and this sort of activity?” “That is inevitable.”

486d

“So, we should not ever admit a forgetful soul into the ranks of those competent for philosophy, but we must search instead for a retentive soul.” “Yes, entirely so.” “What is more, we would say that a person of unharmonious and deformed nature is drawn to mismeasure, and to nothing else.” “Of course.” “And do you think truth is akin to measure or to mismeasure?” “To measure.” “So, we should look for a mind which naturally exhibits measure and good grace in addition to the other qualities, a mind whose own nature allows it to be led easily to the form of anything that is.” “We should, of course.”

486e

“Well then, do you think that the qualities we have listed are in any way unnecessary, or incompatible with one another, for a soul which intends to apprehend ‘what is’ adequately and comprehensively?” “They are absolutely necessary,” he replied.

487a

“Now, is there any way you could criticise a pursuit like this, which no one would be able to engage in properly unless he were naturally retentive, a good learner, magnanimous, gracious, and a friend and relation of truth, justice, courage and sound-mindedness?” “Not even Momus⁹¹ would criticise an activity of that sort,” he said. “Then,” I said, “would you not entrust the city to such people, once they have been perfected

by education and the passage of years?”

487b

Then Adimantus said, “Socrates, no one would be able to contradict you on these matters. However, your hearers have a particular kind of experience every time they hear what you are saying now. They think, due to their inexperience in questioning and answering, that with every question, they are being led a little astray by the argument. But when the little steps are gathered together at the conclusion of the arguments, the defeat proves to be enormous, and quite contrary to the initial assertions. And just like draughts players who are finally boxed in by clever opponents and do not know what move they should make, your 487c hearers are also finally boxed in and do not know what they should say in this quite different game of draughts, played not with counters but with words. However, they have no better knowledge of the truth on account of this process.

487d

“I am speaking in the context of the present discussion. For someone may now say that they cannot oppose you in argument based upon each individual question, but that you should look at the facts. Those who venture into philosophy, not taking it up in their youth for educational purposes and then being free from it, but engaging in it for a long period of time, become for the most part very odd or, we could even say, utterly debased. There are others who seem completely reasonable, except that they are rendered useless to their cities through their encounters with the very subject which you commend.” Having listened to all this, I replied, “Do you think that the people who make these statements are lying?” “I do not know,” he said, “but I would be glad to hear your opinion.” “Then I will tell you. In my opinion, they appear to me anyway to be speaking the truth.” “In that case,” he said, “how is it appropriate to say that the cities will have no relief from evils

until the philosophers rule in them, when we agree that such people are useless to these cities?"

487e

"The question you have asked," I replied, "needs an answer expressed by means of an image." "And I suppose you are quite unaccustomed to speaking in terms of images!" he said. "Very well," I said. "Are you mocking me now that you have landed me with a proposition which is so hard to prove? Anyway, listen to the image so that you may get a better appreciation of how sparingly I make use of images. Indeed, the plight which the most reasonable ones experience at the hands of their cities is so grievous that there is not a single predicament like it. Rather, it is necessary to draw numerous sources together to develop an image of their condition and conduct a defence on their behalf, like the painters who draw goat-stags and hybrid creatures of that sort.

488a

"So, imagine something like this taking place on numerous ships or on a single ship. The captain, though he exceeds everyone on board in size and strength, is, on the other hand, somewhat deaf, his eyesight is also poor, and his knowledge of navigation is not much better. Now, the sailors are arguing with one another over the steering of the ship, each believing that he should steer, though he has not ever learned the skill nor is he able to indicate who his own teacher was, nor when it was that he studied with him. What is more, they assert that the subject is not even teachable, and they do not hesitate to cut into pieces anyone who says that it can be taught. They throng 488b about the captain himself, imploring him and doing anything so that he will turn the helm over to them. Sometimes, if they do not prevail and others are preferred, they kill these others or throw them out of the ship. And having entangled the noble captain with drugs or drink or something 488c else, they assume command of the ship, make use of its contents, and sail on,

drinking and feasting in the manner you expect from such people. As well as this, they praise anyone who is clever at working out how they can gain power by either persuading or overpowering the captain, and they refer to such a person as navigator, helmsman or professor of nautical affairs, and anyone who is not like this they dismiss as useless. But they do not want to hear about the true helmsman, that he ^{488d} must make a study of the year, the seasons, the sky, stars and winds and everything appropriate to this skill, if he really intends to govern a ship. And they do not believe it is possible to be skilled and practised in taking the helm regardless of the wishes of anyone else, and be a skilled helmsman at the same time.

^{488e}

“Now, since this is what is happening on board the ship, do you not think the true helmsman will indeed be called a star-gazer, an idler, and a useless person by the mariners on ships which are organised in this way?” “Very much so,” said Adimantus.

^{489a}

“Now,” I said, “I do not think you will require detailed scrutiny of the image to appreciate that it resembles the disposition of the cities towards the true philosophers. I think you understand what I mean.” “Very much so,” he said.

^{489b}

“Then the first thing is to teach this image to the person who is amazed because philosophers are not honoured in the cities, and try to persuade him that it would be much more amazing if they were honoured.” “Yes, I shall teach him,” he said. “And therefore, what you are saying is true, that the most reasonable of those who engage in philosophy are useless to the multitude. However, tell him that the people who do not make use of the philosophers are responsible for their uselessness, and not those reasonable men. For it is not natural for the helmsman to implore the sailors to be ruled by him, or for the wise to go to the doors of the wealthy. No, whoever invented that ingenious

expression was lying. The truth of ^{489c} nature is that whether you are rich or poor you must go to the doors of the doctors when you are ill, and all who wish to be ruled must go to the doors of those who can rule. The ruler must not implore his subjects to submit to his rule if he is to be of any use at all. But you will not be wide of the mark in comparing the politicians who are ruling now to the sailors we described earlier, and those whom they refer to as useless and as star-gazers to the true helmsmen.” “You are perfectly right,” he said.

^{489d}

“Well, under these circumstances and in these situations, it is not easy for philosophy to be esteemed as the paramount activity by people who are acting in opposition to it. But by far the greatest and most intense detraction of philosophy owes its origin to those who claim to be engaging in philosophic activity. Indeed, you said that the critic of philosophy maintains that most of those who embark upon its study are utterly debased, while the most reasonable are useless, and I admitted you were speaking the truth. Is this so?” “Yes.” “Did we not explain the cause of the uselessness of those who are reasonable?” “Very much so.”

^{489e}

“Do you want us to go on and explain the inevitable debasement of the majority? And if we are able, should we try to demonstrate that philosophy is not responsible for this either?” “Yes, certainly.”

^{490a}

“Then let us listen, and let us speak, once we have reminded ourselves of where we described the sort of nature with which someone who is to be noble and good must be endowed. First, if you recall, it was truth that guided him. He had to pursue it comprehensively by every means, or being a pretender, have no involvement whatsoever with true philosophy.” “Yes, that is what was said.” “And is not this one quality, the pursuit of

truth, in stark contrast to the opinions currently expressed about him?" "Very much so," he said.

490b

"Now, shall we not put up a reasonable defence by saying that someone who actually loves learning would naturally strive towards 'what is', and would not dwell upon each of the many things which seem to be? Rather, he would go on, without blunting his love or relenting in it, until he had grasped the nature of what each thing is in itself, with that part of the soul best fitted to apprehend this, the part which is kindred to it. Once he had drawn close to what actually is, and consorted with it through that part of the soul, having given birth to reason and truth, he would know, and live truly and be nourished, and in this way and in no other would his travail cease." "Nothing could be more reasonable," he said.

490c

"Well then, will he share any love of falsehood, or, on the contrary, will he hate it?" "He will hate it," he said.

490d

"So once truth is leading the way, I presume we would never say that a chorus of evils could follow it." "How could it?" "But what will follow is a healthy and just character accompanied by sound-mindedness." "Correct," he said. "And, in fact, why should it be necessary to arrange the rest of the chorus belonging to the philosophic nature all over again from the beginning? For presumably you do recall that courage, magnanimity, ease of learning and memory turned out to belong to such a nature. And you objected that everyone would indeed be forced to agree with what we are saying, and yet if they set the arguments aside, and looked at the people we are referring to, they would say that some of them are seen to be useless, while the majority are bad in every way. In considering the cause of this criticism we have come to a question. Why precisely are the majority bad? And now, on account of this

question, we have taken up the nature of the true philosophers once more and we are compelled to define it.” “So it is,” he said.

490e

“Then,” I said, “we need to look at the corruption of this nature and how it is destroyed in most cases, with few exceptions – a few who are, of course, referred to not as debased, but as useless. And after that we should look in turn at those who imitate this nature and set themselves up as practitioners of it. When souls of this nature encounter an activity of which they are unworthy, and which is greater than themselves, they constantly fall into error and bring upon philosophy the reputation you describe, in all sorts of ways and in front of everyone.” “What is the corruption you refer to?” he said.

491a

“I shall try to explain this to you if I am able,” I said. “There is one point on which I think everyone will agree with us. A nature like this, possessing all the qualities we prescribed just now for a perfect philosopher, will be few in number and will develop infrequently in people. Do you agree?” “Yes, definitely.” “Now consider the many significant causes of the destruction of these few.” “What causes?”

491b

“Well, the most amazing thing of all to hear is that each of the qualities which we praised in that philosophic nature destroys the soul that possesses it, and tears it away from philosophy. I am referring here to courage, sound-mindedness, and all the qualities we described.” “That is very strange to hear,” he said.

491c

“Yes,” said I. “And in addition to these, all the so-called goods corrupt and tear one away from philosophy: beauty, wealth, strength of body, strong family relationships within the city, and everything associated with these. Now you understand the kind of thing I am referring to.” “I understand,” he said, “and I would love to hear what you have to say in more detail.”

“Then,” I said, “comprehend it correctly in its entirety and it will appear quite clear to you, and the previous statements about these goods will not seem strange.” “What are you telling me to do?” he said.

491d

“In the case of all seeds, or any growth either in the earth or in animals, we know that whatever does not encounter appropriate nourishment, or climate, or location, feels a lack, and the more vigorous it is the more it feels the lack of what is appropriate to it. For badness is more opposed to good than to that which is not good.” “Of course.” “Now, it stands to reason, I believe, that the best nature turns out worse than the ordinary nature under nurture which is alien to it.” “It does.”

491e

“And,” said I, “will we not say, Adimantus, that the same applies to souls? Those with the best natural endowments will become especially bad on encountering bad instruction. Or do you think that enormous injustices and unadulterated baseness originate in an ordinary nature rather than in a high-spirited nature corrupted by its nurture? Will a weak nature ever be responsible for any great good or any great evil?” “No,” he said, “the situation is as you describe it.”

492a

“Then, I presume, the nature we designated as philosophic must develop and attain complete excellence if it obtains the proper instruction. However, if it is not sown, planted and nurtured in the proper manner, it attains the very opposite instead, unless one of the gods happens to come to its aid.

492b

“Or do you also believe, as many do, that some young people are corrupted by sophists, and that certain sophists, operating in private, are a corrupting influence of any significance? Rather, is it not the very people who make these statements who are the greatest sophists, who educate young and old, men and

women, to the utmost, and fashion them according to their will?" "When does this happen?" he said.

492c

"Whenever many people sit down together in large numbers in the assembly," I said, "the law court, the theatre or a military camp, or some other crowded public forum, and with much commotion they censure some things that are said or enacted, and praise others, both in excess. They cry out and applaud, and the rocks and the very place they are in echo with them and redouble the din of their censure and praise. Now, in such a situation, how do you think the young man's heart will fare? What private education will withstand this, and not be swept away by this sort of censure and praise, and be gone, borne away by the flood to wherever it may lead? Won't he declare that what is beautiful or ugly is just what they say it is? Won't he behave as they do and be just like them?"

492d

"Yes, Socrates," he said, "he must." "And yet," I said, "we have still not mentioned the most powerful compulsion." "What is that?" he said. "The compulsion which these educators and sophists employ through their actions when they fail to persuade with words. Or do you not realise that they punish people who are not persuaded, through loss of status, fines and death?" "Yes, most definitely," he said.

492e

"So what other sophist, or what sort of private principles, do you think will prevail in a struggle against such people as these?" "I do not think there is one," he said. "No, there is not," I said. "And even the attempt would be utter folly. For there is not, nor has there been, nor indeed will there ever be, a character distinguished in excellence who has been educated in the system which these people provide, not among humanity anyway, my friend. Of course, according to the proverb, we should make an exception in the case of the divine. For we need

to appreciate that if anything is saved and develops as it should, when cities are in such a predicament ^{493a} as this, it is the providence of God that saves it. If you say this, you will be speaking no evil.” “Well, that is how it seems to me anyway,” he said. “Then,” said I, “there is another proposition you should also accept as well as these.” “What is it?” “Each of the private hirelings, whom certain people call sophists and regard as their professional rivals, do not teach anything other than the doctrines of the masses, the opinions that they form when they are gathered together. And the sophists call this wisdom. It is as if a huge powerful beast was being nurtured and someone made a careful study of its appetites and desires: how it ^{493b} should be approached and how it should be touched; when it is at its most difficult or when it is most docile; how these moods arise, and, indeed, what sounds it usually utters in either circum- ^{493c} stance, and what sounds uttered, in turn, by others make it gentle or wild. Suppose having learned all this through years of experience of being with the creature, he called it wisdom, set it up as a skill, and turned to teaching it. Without knowing if any of those doctrines or desires was beautiful or ugly, good or bad, just or unjust, he would decide everything according to the opinions of the huge animal. Whatever pleased it he would call good, whatever upset it he would call bad, and this is the only argument he would have on the matter. Whatever was necessary he would call just and beautiful, without having seen the nature of the necessary and the nature of the good, and the extent to which they really differ, or being able to demonstrate this to anyone else. Now, by Zeus, do you not think a person like this would be a strange educator?” “I think so,” he said.

^{493d}

“Well, is there any difference between this man and someone who believes that discerning the mood and pleasures of these numerous, variegated gatherings of people is wisdom, whether it concerns painting, music or even politics? For regardless of

how someone deals with them, whether he presents poetry or some other product or service to the city, once he turns the multitude into his masters beyond the limit of necessity, the so-called ‘necessity of Diomedes’⁹² compels him to produce whatever they praise. But have you ever yet heard someone make the case that these productions are in truth good and beautiful, based on an argument which was not utterly laughable?” “No, and I do not think I ever shall,” he said.

493e

“Well, now that you have understood all this, let me remind you of something. Is there any way that the masses will accept or believe that there is such a thing as beauty itself, rather than many beautiful things, or anything ‘by itself’, rather than many particular things?” “Not in the least,” he said. “So it is impossible for the multitude to be a philosopher,” I replied. “Impossible.” “And so those who engage in philosophy must be censured by the multitude.” “They must.” “And, of course, by those private educators who associate with the crowds and who long to please them.” “Obviously.”

494a

“Now, do you see any salvation for the philosophic nature emerging from all this, so that it will persist in its activity and reach its objective? Think in terms of what was said earlier. We did agree that ease of learning, memory, courage, and magnanimity belong to this nature.” “Yes.” “Will not a person like this, from his very childhood, be the first among them all in everything, especially if his body also develops like his soul?” “He must be,” he said.

494b

“Then his associates and fellow citizens will want to make use of him for their own purposes, once he comes of age.” “How could they do otherwise?” “So, they will fall at his feet, and petition him and honour him, laying on their flattery as they anticipate his impending power.” “That is what tends to happen, anyway,”

he said.

494c

“Now, what do you think a person like this will do under such circumstances,” I said, “especially if he happens to belong to a great city in which he is wealthy and of noble birth, and he is tall and good-looking besides? Will he not be filled with unbounded confidence, believing himself competent to manage the affairs of the Greeks and non-Greeks? Will he not exalt himself on account of this, and be loaded with pretension and empty thinking which is devoid of reason?” “Yes, very much so,” he said.

494d

“Well, if one were to approach a person in such a predicament gently and tell him the truth – that there is no reason in him but he does need reason, and that anyone who does not have it must work like a slave to acquire it – do you think it would be easy for him to hear this in the midst of such corrupting influences?” “Far from it,” he said.

494e

“What if one such person somehow becomes aware of philosophy,” I said, “turns to it, and is drawn there on account of good rearing and an affinity with reasoned arguments? How do we think the others will respond when they presume that they will lose his influence and companionship? Will they not do anything, or say anything, through private conspiracies and public confrontations to prevent him from being persuaded, and to prevent the persuader from succeeding?” “Yes, they must,” he said.

495a

“Then is there any way that such a person will enter into philosophy?” “Certainly not.” “Do you see now that we were not far wrong when we said that the very qualities of the philosophic nature, once they encounter bad nurture, are in a way responsible for making a man give up the activity? And the

same goes for the so-called goods, such as wealth or any acquisition of that sort.” “Yes, what was said was correct.”

495b

“So, wonderful friend, such is the extent of the corruption, and the sort of destruction, which afflicts the very best nature with regard to this supreme activity, and we assert that this nature is a rare occurrence in any case. And, indeed, from the ranks of these men come the people who inflict the greatest evils on cities and individuals, and the greatest good too should they happen to be inclined in that direction. But a weak nature never does anything significant, either for a city or for an individual.” “Very true,” he said.

495c

“And now that these people who are most suited to philosophy have gone away like this, they leave it alone and incomplete, while they themselves live an unseemly and untrue life. Philosophy, on the other hand, is like an orphan without relatives. Unworthy characters arrive on the scene and they subject it to shame and derision, levelling the sort of criticisms you describe, that some of its associates are worthless, while most of them are responsible for countless evils.” “Well, yes, that is what they say anyway.”

495d

“And what they say is quite reasonable. For other puny specimens of humanity observe that this place is becoming empty, though it is full of fair titles and reputations. Like men who flee from prison to take refuge in temples, those who happen to be cleverest in their own little subject are glad to jump from their professions into philosophy. Nevertheless, philosophy, in spite of its predicament, retains a most worthy reputation in comparison with the other occupations. So of ^{495e} course many people whose nature is undeveloped aspire to this, but their souls are stunted and crushed by vulgarities, just as their bodies are deformed by their professions and occupations.

This is inevitable is it not?" "Very much so," he said. "Now," I said, "do you think they are any different to behold than a small, bald-headed bronze-worker who has acquired some money, has recently been freed from bondage, washed himself at a bathhouse, is wearing a brand new garment, and is decked out like a bridegroom, intending to marry his master's daughter because she is poor and abandoned?" "No, there is not much difference," he said.

496a

"And what sort of offspring are such unions likely to bring forth? Will it not be illegitimate and ordinary?" "It really must be." "Well then, what sort of ideas and opinions would we say are produced when those who are unworthy of education draw near to philosophy and consort with it when they do not deserve to? Would it not be best, in truth, to call them sophisms, possessing nothing genuine or worthy of true intelligence?" "Entirely so," he said.

496b

"Well, Adimantus," I said, "what is left is some tiny remnant of those who are worthy to consort with philosophy, perhaps a noble and well-reared character who has suffered exile, has no access to corrupting influences and remains naturally by its side. Or sometimes a great soul may grow up in a small city, show no respect for the affairs of that city and may see beyond them. Or perhaps some few with natural endowments may come to it from other professions, for which they rightly show an appropriate disregard. The bridle of our friend Theages⁹³ may also be able to restrain someone. Yes, indeed, all other factors in Theages' life gave him cause to give up philosophy. However, his inclination to physical illness keeps him out of public affairs and acts as a restraint. But my own sign,⁹⁴ the daimon, is not worth mentioning, for I believe it has happened to scarcely anyone else before.

496c

“Now, those who belong to this small group have tasted the sweetness and blessedness of this possession, and can also see the madness of the multitude quite well, realising that in a sense no one does anything reasonable in the conduct of civic affairs, nor is there an ally with whom a man could go to the aid of justice and still survive. Instead, he is like a man who has fallen in with wild animals, has no desire to conspire in wrongdoing but is not up to the task of resisting all their savagery, a man who will perish before he is of any benefit to the city or his friends, and would be of no use to himself or anyone else. Having understood all this through reflection, he is at peace and attends to his own affairs, like a man in a storm of wind-driven dust and rain who crouches ^{496d} beneath a low wall. And seeing that all else is crammed full of lawlessness, he is content if somehow he can live this life here purified of injustice and unholy deeds, and take his departure with good hope, gracious and kindly as he goes.” “But surely,” he said, “if he were to depart, having accomplished this, it would be no mean achievement.”

^{496e}

“Nor the greatest possible achievement either,” I said, “unless he encounters a form of government which is propitious. For he himself will develop fully in a propitious city, and will save what is public and what is private. “And now the origin of the slanders against philosophy and the injustice of the charges have, in my opinion, been properly explained, unless you have anything else to say.” “No,” he said, “I have nothing else to say on this topic. But which of the present forms of government is propitious to philosophy?”

^{497a}

“None whatsoever,” I said. “That is the very accusation I am making. Not one city of those presently in existence is worthy of the philosophic nature, and therefore it is contorted and altered. Just as an alien seed planted in foreign ground tends to

be overpowered and fades into the local countryside, this type, in like manner, no longer holds onto his own capacity, but degenerates into a character which is not his own. However, if he encounters the most excellent form of government, as excellent as himself, then it will be evident that this type is truly divine, while the others are human both in their natures and in their activities. Obviously the next thing you will ask is what this form of government is.”

497b

“No, you are wrong,” he said. “I was not about to ask you that, but rather whether this is the very form of government we have been describing whilst establishing our city, or a different form.”

497c

“In general terms, it is that form,” I said. “However, it was also stated earlier that there must always be one person in the city possessing the same understanding of the form of government which you, the lawgiver, held when you were instituting the laws.” “Yes, that was said,” he replied.

497d

“But this was not made sufficiently clear,” I said, “because we were afraid of your objections which show that the proof of this is long and difficult. Indeed, what now remains is not at all easy to recount.” “What does remain?” “The manner in which a city practising philosophy may avoid destruction. For obviously all great undertakings are prone to failure, and it is a true saying that ‘hard is the good’.”

497e

“But we should bring the proof to a conclusion anyway by making this point clear.” “It is not lack of will,” I said, “but lack of ability, if anything, which may prevent this. And since you are here you will see how eager I am. Behold the impetuosity and rashness with which I now declare that the city must take up this philosophic activity in the opposite manner to the

present manner.” “How?”

498a

“Nowadays,” I said, “those who take up the subject are youths just out of childhood, before they turn to household affairs and money-making, who get close to the most difficult aspect of the activity and then give up. I am referring to those with the greatest philosophic pretensions. And when I mention ‘the most difficult aspect’, I mean reasoned arguments. Subsequently, if they are invited by others who engage in philosophy, they prefer to participate as listeners, and they think that this is significant for they regard it as a necessary pastime. But in their later years, save of course for a few, they are extinguished more comprehensively than Heraclitus’ sun,⁹⁵ insofar as they are never again rekindled.” “What should they do?” he asked.

498b

“The complete opposite. When they are youths and children, they should engage in a youthful form of education and philosophy, and at a time when their bodies are developing and reaching manhood, these should be very well cared for in order to procure a servant for philosophy. “But once they reach the age at which the soul starts to become mature, they should intensify the exercises of the soul. And later, when the strength abates and they become unfit for political ^{498c} or military affairs, at that stage they should be left to indulge in philosophy without restraint and do nothing else unless as a pastime, if they are to live happily, and when they die, crown the life they have lived here with a propitious destiny beyond.” “Socrates,” he said, “it really does seem to me that you have, at best, spoken enthusiastically. However, I think that most of your listeners are resisting you with even greater enthusiasm and will not be persuaded at all, beginning with Thrasymachus.”

498d

“Do not speak ill of me and Thrasymachus,” I replied. “We have only just become friends, not that we were enemies before that.

For we shall not give up this effort until we either persuade him and the others, or make some preparation for that life wherein they come into being once more and encounter arguments such as these.” “You are referring to quite a short time period,” he said. “Yes, but it is really nothing in relation to all time,” I replied. “However, the fact that most people are not persuaded by what is being said is no wonder at all. For they have never beheld what is ^{498e} now being described. No, just a lot more expressions of this sort, which cohere with one another due to contrivance rather than the chance occurrence which happened just now. But they have never yet seen a number of men, or even one man, who is perfectly balanced and coherent in virtue as far as this is possible, in both word and deed, holding power in a city which is just like himself. Or do you think they have?” “Not at all.” “Nor, blessed friend, have they listened properly to beautiful and free discourse, of a kind which exerts itself in every way to seek truth for the sake of knowledge, showing only a distant regard for clever and argumentative words whose aim, both in law courts and in private gatherings, is nothing except reputation and contention?” “No, they do not have this experience, either,” he said.

^{499a}

“Well,” I said, “on account of these issues, and anticipating them, at the time we were afraid. But nevertheless, under the compulsion of truth, we said that neither a city, nor a form of government, nor an individual person either, would attain perfection until some necessity, perchance, compels those few philosophers – who are not corrupted but who have just been referred to as useless – to take responsibility for the city, whether they want to or not, and also constrains the city to heed them. Or, until a true love of true philosophy, through some divine providence, inspires the sons of our present kings or potentates, or even the men themselves. And I am saying that

there is no reason why either or both of these outcomes is impossible. For in that case, we would rightly be laughed at for uttering nothing but empty pieties. Is this not so?" "It is so."

499b

"Then, if some necessity had arisen for those at the very pinnacle of philosophy to take charge of a city, in the boundless ages of the past, in some foreign land which is somehow far beyond our view, or there is such a need at present, or if this will ever happen in future, then I am prepared to uphold the argument that there has been a form of government such as we have described, and there is and will be such a form whenever the Muse of philosophy has come to power in a city. For it is not impossible to bring this into being, neither are we describing impossibilities, but we do acknowledge that it is difficult." "And that is how it seems to me too," he said.

499c

"And would you agree," I said, "that this is not how it seems to most people?" "Perhaps," he replied. "Blessed friend," I said, "do not level undue criticism at the masses in this manner. They will hold a different opinion if you are encouraging, rather than adversarial, as you undo this slander against the love of learning. Show them the people you call philosophers, and define their nature and the activity just as you did before, so that they will not think you are referring to the people whom ^{499d} they themselves regard as philosophers. And once they see this, surely you agree that they will hold a different opinion and respond differently. Or do you think that anyone gets angry with someone who is not being angry, or acts grudgingly towards someone who is ungrudging and is a generous, gentle person? Actually, I shall anticipate your answer and say that it may happen in a few cases, but in most cases such an angry nature does not arise." "And I agree with you, of course," he said.

499e

“And will you not also agree that the angry disposition of most people towards philosophy is caused by those outsiders who rush in wildly where they do not belong, abusing one another, possessed by a love of adversity, always framing their arguments in relation to other people, an activity utterly inappropriate to philosophy?” “Very much so,” he replied.

500a

“Yes, and surely you would also agree, Adimantus, that someone whose mind is truly directed towards things that are, has no time to look down upon the affairs of men and do battle with them, ^{500b} filled with envy and hostility. No, he looks towards things which are in their assigned place, which are always the same, and seeing that these neither act unjustly nor are treated unjustly by one another, but are completely ordered and in accord with reason, he imitates them and becomes as like unto them as possible. Or do you think there is any way that a person who delights in something, and consorts with it, can avoid imitating it?” “Impossible,” he said.

500c

“Then the philosopher, consorting with the divine and the orderly, becomes as divine and orderly as is possible for a human being. But there is enormous prejudice from all quarters.” “Yes, entirely so.” “Now, should some need arise for him to practise instilling what he sees in that place into the private or public affairs of humanity, and not merely to work upon himself, do you think he would prove to be a poor artificer of sound-mindedness and justice and the sum total of public excellence?” “Not in the least,” he said.

500d

“But if the masses actually realise that we are speaking the truth about the philosopher, will they still be angry with the philosophers, and disbelieve us when we say that a city will not ever be happy at all unless it is drawn by draughtsmen who have recourse to the divine pattern?” “They will not be angry

once they realise this,” he said. “But what manner of drawing are you referring to?”

500e

“Having taken the city,” I said, “as if it were a writing tablet, and the customs of humanity too, they would first make them clean, and this is no easy task. But in any case, you know that they would immediately differ from others in this respect; they would not be prepared to take responsibility for a person or a city, or write laws, unless these were either clean when they received them, or they themselves made them clean.”

501a

“And rightly so,” he said. “And after that, do you not think they would sketch an outline of the form of government?” “Of course.”

501b

“Then, I presume, they would turn their gaze in both directions as they filled in the details, looking towards what is naturally just and beautiful and sound, and everything of that sort, and towards their counterpart in the realm of humanity. Mixing together and blending various activities, they would fashion the likeness of a man by referring to what Homer calls ‘the form and image of God arising in human beings’.”⁹⁶ “Correct,” he said.

501c

“And I imagine they would erase one feature and then draw in another feature, until they had made the character of humanity as beloved of God as it can possibly be.” “The picture could scarcely be more beautiful,” he said. “Now,” I said, “are we somehow persuading the people who are ‘rushing at us in battle array’ that this is the sort of draughtsman of forms of government we commended to them earlier? They were angry because we were going to hand the city over to this man, but are they any gentler now that they have heard this?” “Very much so,” he replied, “if they are sound-minded, anyway.”

501d

“Yes, but how could they dispute this? Would they say that the philosophers are not lovers of truth and ‘what is’?” “That would indeed be strange,” he said. “Or that their nature, as we have described it, is not akin to the very best nature?” “They cannot say that either.”

501e

“Well then, will they say that such a nature, encountering the appropriate practices, will not be perfectly good and philosophic, if any nature can? Or will they say that the people we have excluded have a better chance?” “Certainly not.” “So, will they still be angry when we say that until the philosophic type assume power, there will be no cessation of evils for cities or for citizens, nor will the city which we are describing in fabled words ever be perfectly realised in action.” “Perhaps they will be less angry,” he said. “May we say not that they are less angry, but they have become completely gentle and have been persuaded, so that they are inclined to agree with us, even if only from shame?” “Yes, certainly,” he said.

502a

“Then let us assume,” I said, “that they are persuaded of this. Is there anyone who will argue nevertheless that there is no chance of the offspring of kings and potentates turning out to be philosophers by nature?” “Not a single person will argue that,” he replied. “Can anyone maintain that such people absolutely must be destroyed once they do come into being? We do agree of course that they are difficult to save, but is there anyone who would contend that throughout all time not even one of them has ever been saved?” “How could anyone maintain that?”

502b

“But surely,” I said, “if one such person comes into being, and the city is co-operative, that is sufficient to accomplish everything which is now cast into doubt?” “Yes, it is sufficient,”

he said. "For I presume," said I, "that once the ruler has set down the laws and practices we have described, it is certainly not impossible for the citizens to be willing to enact them." "No, not at all."

502c

"Well then, would it be any surprise if others held the opinions which we hold, or is this impossible?" "Well, I do not think so anyway," he said. "And, indeed, in my opinion we have provided sufficient evidence already that these arrangements, if they are possible, are the very best." "Yes, quite sufficient." "Well now, it seems we are coming to the conclusion that when it comes to the enactment of laws, the arrangements we are describing are the best, if they can be enacted. However they are difficult, but not impossible, to implement." "Yes, that is what we are concluding," he said.

502d

"Therefore, since this issue has with some effort reached a conclusion, we should of course go on and discuss whatever remains: the manner in which the saviours fit into our form of government, the subjects and activities upon which this is based, and the ages at which they will take them up." "We should indeed discuss this," he said.

502e

"And nothing came of my earlier cleverness," I said, "in passing over the difficult question of the possession of women, the begetting of children, and the appointment of rulers. I knew that the completely true version would attract hostility, and is also difficult to implement, but now it proves necessary to give an account of it in any case. "Well, matters relating to women and children have been concluded. However the question of the rulers must, in a sense, be dealt with from the beginning. We said, if you recall, that they must prove themselves to be lovers of the city, tested both in pleasure and in pain, and must show that they never set aside this principle in the face of hardship,

or fear, or any adversity whatsoever. Those who cannot do this must be rejected, while anyone who turns out to be entirely pure, like gold tested in the fire, should be installed as a ruler and be accorded honours, both in life and after ^{503a} death, yea, and prizes too. These were the sorts of things we were saying while the argument turned aside and hid itself for fear of initiating this particular discussion.” “What you are saying is very true,” he replied. “I do remember.”

^{503b}

“Yes, my friend. I was reluctant to say what I have just dared to say,” said I, “but now we should have the courage to declare that philosophers must be appointed as guardians, in the strict sense of the word.” “Yes, we should say so,” he replied. “Now, bear in mind that they will probably be few in number. For the various qualities of the nature we described must be applicable to them, and those qualities are seldom inclined to develop together in the same person, but are usually dispersed throughout the population.” “What do you mean?” he said.

^{503c}

“You know that ease of learning, memory, sagacity, acuity, and whatever is associated with these, along with spiritedness and magnificence of mind, tend not to develop along with a desire to live an orderly life in peace and constancy. Rather, such people are borne by their own brilliance wherever chance may lead, and all constancy goes out of them.” “What you say is true.”

^{503d}

“On the other hand, do not characters that are constant and not easily swayed, in which we place more trust, that are unmoved in the face of terrors on the battlefield, also act in just the same way when faced with things to be learned? They are hard to move and hard to teach, as if they had been paralysed, and are full of sleep and yawning if they must apply themselves to such a task.” “That is what happens,” he said. “But we stated that a

person must partake of both characters in proper and fair measure, or else he should not be given a share of education in the truest sense, or of honour, or of rule.” “Correct,” he said. “Do you not think that this will be rare?” “How could it not be?”

503e

“Then they should be tested under the hardships, fears and pleasures we described earlier. And there is also the point we just mentioned, which we passed over before, that they should be put through exercises in many branches of learning to see if they will be able to endure the most important sub- 504a jects, or will prove to be cowards, just as people also prove to be cowards in the other situations.” “Yes of course,” he said, “it is quite appropriate to consider the matter in this way. But what sort of important subjects are you actually referring to?” “You remember, I presume,” said I, “that once we had distinguished three parts of soul we came to conclusions about what justice is, and about what sound-mindedness, courage and wisdom each is.” “Well,” he said, “if I did not remember, I would have no right to hear the rest of this discussion.” “Do you also remember what was said before that?” “What sort of thing?”

504b

“I believe we said that in order to obtain the clearest possible view of these, another longer, circuitous route would be necessary, and they would become apparent to someone who took that route. However, we said we could add proofs which follow from the previous discussion, and you agreed that this was sufficient, and what was said was said on this basis, though it seemed to me to lack precision. But whether it was satisfactory to you is for you to say.” “Well, to me it was satisfactory in some measure, and the others seemed to think so too.”

504c

“But, my friend,” I said, “in such matters a measure which leaves out any aspect of ‘what is’ does not act as a measure at

all, for nothing incomplete is a measure of anything. However, it does sometimes seem to some people that enough has been achieved already, and it is not necessary to search any further.” “Yes, lots of people feel like this due to laziness,” he said. “But this feeling has no place whatsoever in a guardian of the city and the laws.” “That is reasonable,” he said.

504d

“Then, my friend,” I said, “the longer route must be taken by someone like this, and he should devote just as much labour to learning as to gymnastics. Otherwise, as we just said, he will never attain the objective of the greatest and most important subject.” “So, is there something greater than justice and whatever else we described?” he asked. “Are these not the greatest?” “There are greater,” I said, “and in those cases we must behold no mere outline as we did just now. No, we cannot avoid giving a complete and comprehensive account. Would it not be ridiculous to make all these efforts to achieve the utmost precision and clarity in issues of little significance, and in contrast deem the greatest issues unworthy of the greatest precision?” “Very much so,” he said. “But do you think that anyone will let you go without asking what the greatest subject is, and what it deals with?”

504e

“Not at all,” I said, “you should ask. You have heard the answer often enough, that is for sure, but now either you cannot think of it, or alternatively you intend to make work for me by raising objections. And I suspect it is more the latter, since you have often heard that the form of the good is the greatest subject, and that justice and the others become useful and beneficial through recourse to this. You know quite well that I am going to talk about this, and will also say that our knowledge of it is inadequate. And if we do not know this, but have comprehensive knowledge of other matters without knowing this, you know it is of no benefit to us, nor is anything else we

acquire, without acquiring the good. Or do you think there is any advantage in acquiring everything without acquiring the good? Or in understanding everything else except the good, but understanding nothing fair and good?" "By Zeus, I do not," he said.

505a

"Well now, you also know that to most people pleasure seems to be the good, but to the more refined people it seems to be understanding." "So it does," he said.

505b

"And you know, my friend, that those who believe this are unable to indicate what this understanding is. Rather, they are finally compelled to say that it is understanding of 'the good'." "Yes, it is quite comical," he said. "Isn't that inevitable," I said, "if they criticise us because we do not know the good while talking to us as if we did know it? For they say that it is understanding of the good, as if for our part we follow what they are saying whenever they utter the phrase 'the good'." "Very true," he said.

505c

"And what about those who define pleasure as the good? Are they any less adrift than the others? Are they not also compelled to agree that there are bad pleasures?" "Definitely." "In that case it follows, I presume, that they are agreeing that the same things are both good and bad. Is this so?" "Of course." "Is it not evident then that there are many intense disputes about it?" "Inevitably."

505d

"What about this? Is it not evident that many people would choose whatever seems to be just and fair when it comes to actions, possessions, or reputations, even if these are not actually just and fair? But no one is ever satisfied with acquiring what seems to be good. No, they search for things that are good, and in this case they utterly despise seeming." "Very much so,"

he said.

505e

“So, there is something that every soul pursues, and for the sake of which it performs all actions, possessing an intuition that there is such a thing. But it is perplexed, and cannot apprehend precisely what it is, or resort to a stable belief as it does in other pursuits, and on this account it loses any benefit from the other pursuits. Now, would we say that our guardians, the very best people in the 506a city, to whom everything is entrusted, should be in such dark ignorance about something as important as this?” “Least of all,” he said. “Anyway,” I said, “I suspect that when there is ignorance as to how exactly the just and fair are also good, they will obtain a guardian who is not good for much, since he will be ignorant of this issue. And my intuition is that no one will have adequate knowledge of the just and the fair, until the good is known.” “A sound intuition indeed,” he said.

506b

“Will not our form of government attain perfect order if a guardian such as this, someone with knowledge of these matters, watches over it?” “It must,” he replied. “But, Socrates, are you saying that the good is knowledge or pleasure, or something else besides these?” “What an excellent man you are,” I said. “Indeed, it has been evident for some time that you would not accept the opinions of others about this.” “Yes, Socrates, it does not seem right to me to be able to express other people’s opinions but not your own, when you have been engaged in these issues for such a long time.”

506c

“Then what about this?” I said. “Does it seem right to you for someone who does not know to speak as if he knows?” “He certainly should not speak as if he knows,” he replied. “But he should be prepared to state what he believes as if he believed it.” “Yes, but have you not observed that opinions devoid of knowledge are all disgraceful? That the very best of them are

blind? Or do you think that those who form true opinions, devoid of reason, are any different from blind men travelling along the right road?" "Not one bit," he replied.

506d

"So, would you like to contemplate the disgraceful, the blind and the deformed, when it is possible to hear what is bright and beautiful from other sources?" "By Zeus, Socrates," said Glaucon, "do not give up when you are almost at the end. Indeed, we shall be satisfied even if you give an account of the good, in the same way that you also gave an account of justice, sound-mindedness and the others." "And so shall I, my friend," I said, "I shall be quite satisfied. But I fear that I shall not be able, and in my enthusiasm I shall disgrace myself and incur ridicule. Instead, blessed friends, let us set aside for now this question of what precisely is the good, for it appears to me that to attain what I ^{506e} now have in mind is beyond this current endeavour. However, I am prepared to describe something which appears to be the offspring of the good, and to resemble it very closely, if that is acceptable to you. Otherwise, let us leave it." "Just speak," he said. "You will repay the story of the father some other time."

507a

"I wish that I could give you this," I said, "and that you could receive it and not the mere 'interest'⁹⁷ I am giving you now. Anyway, you should certainly accept this interest and offspring of the good itself. However, be careful, in case I somehow deceive you unintentionally with a false account of the interest." "We will be as careful as we can," he said. "Just speak."

507b

"I will begin," I said, "once I have come to an agreement with you and reminded you of what was said previously, and has often been said on other occasions too." "What are you referring to?" he asked. "We say," I said, "that there are many

beautiful things, many good things, and so on, and we define them in words.” “Yes, that is what we say.” “And we say there is beauty itself and good itself, and the same applies to everything else we then designated as many. Furthermore, based upon a single form belonging to each multiplicity, designating the form as being one, we refer to it as ‘what each is’.” “This is so.” “And we say that the many are seen but are not known by reason, while the forms are known by reason but are not seen.” “Entirely so.”

507c

“Now, with which of our faculties do we see visible objects?” “With sight.” “And with hearing we hear whatever is heard, and with the other senses we perceive all that is perceived. Is this so?” “Of course.” “Now,” I said, “have you thought about the great extravagance with which the artificer of the senses fashioned the faculty of seeing and being seen?” “Not much,” he replied. “Well, consider this: do hearing and sound require another factor so that the one can hear, and the other be heard, a third element in the absence of which hearing will not hear and sound will not be heard?” “They require nothing,” he replied.

507d

“Yes,” I said, “and I believe there is no such requirement in most other instances, though I do not wish to say there are none at all. Or do you have any examples?” “No, I do not,” he said. “But do you realise that the faculty of sight and visibility does have this requirement?” “How so?” “Sight is presumably present in the eyes and their possessor attempts to make use of it. Colour is present too, but in the absence of a third factor naturally adapted to the particular purpose, you know that sight will see nothing, and colours will be invisible.” “What factor are you referring to?” he asked. “It is what you call light,” I replied. “What you are saying is true,” he said.

507e

“Then, the sense of sight and the capacity to be seen are yoked together by a bond, more noble in no small measure than other combinations, since light does not lack nobility.” “On the contrary,” he said, “it is far from ignoble.”

508a

“Now, can you say which lord of the gods in heaven is responsible for this light, by which our sight can see so clearly and by which the visible things can be seen?” “I can say what you or anyone else can say, for obviously you are asking about the sun.” “Well, is there a particular natural relation of sight to this god?” “How is it related?” “Neither sight itself, nor the eye in which we say sight arises, are the sun.” “No, they are not.” “And yet I believe the eye, of all the organs of sense, is most like the sun in form.”

508b

“Very like.” “And is not the power it possesses acquired as an influx dispensed from the sun?” “Yes, entirely so.” “In which case the sun is not sight. However, being the cause of sight, is it seen by sight itself?” “Quite so,” he replied.

508c

“Then you should realise”, I said, “that what I am describing is the offspring of the good, which the good itself generated in a particular relation to itself. Insofar as the good, in the realm of reason, relates to reason and whatever is known by reason, so does the sun, in the realm of sight, relate to sight and whatever is seen by sight.” “In what way?” he asked. “Tell me more.” “You know,” I said, “that whenever the eyes are no longer turned to objects whose colours receive the light of day, but to objects in the dim light of the night, their keenness is blunted, and they almost seem blind as though there is no clear vision in them.” “Very much so,” he replied.

508d

“And yet, I believe, when they turn to objects on which the sun shines, they see clearly, and it appears that there is vision in

those same eyes.” “Of course.” “Then, you should also understand the condition of the soul in the same way. Whenever it rests on something upon which truth and ‘what is’ shine, it reasons and knows it, and appears to possess reason. However, when directed to something compounded with darkness which comes into being and is destroyed, the soul forms opinions, sees dimly, changes its opinions back and forth, and in this situation seems not to possess reason.” “Yes, that is how it seems.”

508e

“Then, you should declare that the form of the good bestows truth upon whatever is known, and confers the power of knowing on the knower. Being the cause of knowledge and truth, you should think of it as knowable. However, although knowledge and truth are both beautiful, you would be right to regard this as different from them, and even more beautiful than both of them. And just as in the previous case, it is right to regard light and sight as resembling the sun in form, but it is not right to believe they are the sun, so also in this case it is right to regard knowledge and truth as 509a both resembling the good in form, but it is not right to believe that either of them is the good. No, the character of the good should be accorded even greater honour.” “You are speaking of an unparalleled beauty,” he said, “if it bestows knowledge and truth, and exceeds them in beauty. For you are surely not saying that it is pleasure.” “Please show respect,” I said, “and consider a further aspect of its image.” “In what way?”

509b

“I assume you will agree that the sun bestows not only the ability to be seen upon visible objects, but also their generation and increase and nurture, though the sun itself is not generation.” “How could I disagree?” “Then not only does the knowability of whatever is known derive from the good, but also what it is, and its being, is conferred on it through that,

though the good is not being, but is even beyond being, exceeding it in dignity and power.”

509c

Then Glaucon exclaimed quite hilariously, “By Apollo, it is utterly supernatural!” “Yes,” I said, “and you are responsible for making me express my opinions about it.” “And you should not stop at all,” he replied. “At least give us more details about this simile of the sun, if there is anything you are leaving out.” “In fact,” I said, “I am leaving out quite a lot.” “Well, you should not omit even a little,” he said. “I think I shall omit a lot,” I said. “Nevertheless, to the extent that it is possible at present, I shall 509d not leave anything out deliberately.” “Then do not,” he said. “Keep in mind what we have been saying, that there are two things, one having lordship of the realm and kind known by reason while the other is lord of the visible realm. Now, I hope you do not think I am just playing with words,⁹⁸ but do you now understand that there are these two kinds, one known by sight and the other by reason?” “I understand that.”

509e

“Then, take a line which has been divided into two unequal sections, one corresponding to the kind known by sight, and the other to the kind known by reason. Divide each section once more in the same ratio, and you will have an expression of their relative clarity and obscurity in the realm of sight. There, one section consists of images, and by images I mean shadows first, and then appearances produced in water, and in anything dense, smooth and polished, and indeed everything else of that sort. Do you understand?” “I do understand.”

510a

“Then you should designate the other section as that which the first one resembles – the animals around us, everything that grows, and the entire class of inanimate objects.” “Very well,” he said. “And would you also be prepared to say that this division makes a distinction involving truth and its absence, for

as an object of opinion relates to an object of knowledge, so also does a likeness relate to whatever it is like?" "I would indeed," he replied. "Now, you should go on to consider how the section known by reason is to be divided." "Yes, in what way?"

510b

"In this way. In one of the sections, the soul is compelled to search, based on hypotheses, using as images what had previously been imitated, and proceeding not to a first principle but to a conclusion. In the other section however, it also goes on from hypothesis to an un-hypothesised first principle, and based upon forms themselves, it conducts its approach through them, without the images used before." "I don't really understand what you are saying," he said.

510c

"Then I will try again," I said, "for you will learn more easily from these preliminary examples. Indeed, I am sure you appreciate that those involved with geometry or calculation, or such subjects, hypothesise the odd and the even, the various shapes, the three kinds of angles, and other kindred hypotheses, depending on the particular approach. They assume that these are already known, turn them into hypotheses, and see no value in giving an account of them, either to themselves or to anyone else, since they are obvious to everyone. Beginning from these, they proceed with the remaining issues, and arrive at consistent conclusions about the matter they set out to investigate." "Yes," he said. "I certainly know this."

510d

"In that case, you also appreciate that they make use of the visible forms, and construct their arguments in relation to them, although it is not the visible forms that they have in mind but the things which they resemble. They construct their arguments with an eye to the square itself, and the diameter itself, and not the one in the diagram. The same applies to the other instances. They take the objects which are fabricated or

drawn, objects which have shadows, and images in water, and use them in turn as images, seeking to discern the entities themselves, which may only be discerned through thought.” “What you are saying is true,” he said.

510e

“Well, this is the form I described as ‘known by reason’. However, the soul is compelled to employ hypothesis in its investigation of it, not proceeding to a first principle, since it is unable to transcend any higher than hypotheses. Instead, it employs as images the very objects which are imitated in 511a the lower division, objects which are regarded as clear and worthy of honour when compared to their images.”

511b

“I understand that you are referring to the province of geometry and related subjects,” he said. “Then you should appreciate that I am referring to the other division of the realm, known by reason, as what reasoned argument itself attains through the power of dialectic. It does not turn the hypotheses into first principles, but into actual underpinnings, like steps or points of attack, so that it may go as far as the un-hypothesised, to the first principle of all. Having attained that, and proceeding 511c once more to follow whatever depends on that, it descends in this way to a conclusion, having no recourse whatsoever to any sense object, but to forms themselves – through forms, to forms, and ending in forms.” “I appreciate that,” he said, “but not very well, for you seem to me to be describing a vast undertaking. Anyway, you wish to establish that the realm contemplated by the knowledge of dialectic, the realm of ‘what is’ and what is known by intelligence, is clearer than what is contemplated by what we call skills. In skills, the hypotheses are the first principles, and those who discern their objects, despite the fact that they must see them through understanding rather than through the senses, enquire on the basis of hypotheses. However, 511d because they do not ascend to a principle, you do

not think they employ intelligence in relation to these objects, even though they are objects of intelligence associated with a principle. And you seem to me to be calling the faculty of geometers and the like not intelligence, but understanding, since understanding is something in between opinion and intelligence.”

511e

“You have given a very competent exposition,” I said. “And corresponding to the four sections, you should assume four qualities arising in the soul: intelligence corresponding to the highest, and understanding to the second, assign belief to the third, imagination to the last. And arrange them in proportion, accepting that these partake of clarity insofar as their objects partake of truth.” “I understand,” he said, “and I agree. And I am arranging them as you suggest.”

BOOK VII

514a

“Now,” I said, “after this you should compare our nature, in respect of education and lack of education, to a condition such as the following. Behold men in a sort of underground cave-like dwelling, with a long entrance facing towards the light along the side of the entire cave. They have ^{514b} been in this place from childhood, with bonds both on their legs and on their necks, so that they remain looking only at what is in front of them, being unable to turn their heads around because of the chain on the neck. “Light comes to them from a fire burning above and at a distance behind them, and higher up, between the fire and the prisoners, there is a path, and you can see a low wall built along the path, just like the screens which puppet-makers place in front of themselves, over which they display their puppets.” “I see,” he said.

514c

“Besides this, you should also see men carrying a variety of objects past the wall, including statues ^{515a} of men and other animals made of wood, stone and all sorts of materials. Some of the object-carriers are likely to be speaking, while others are silent.” “You are describing a strange image,” he said, “and strange prisoners.” “They are just like us,” I said. “For in the first place, do you think such people would ever have seen anything of themselves, or one another, apart from the shadows cast by the fire onto the cave wall in front of them?”

^{515b}

“How could they,” he replied, “if they were compelled to keep their heads motionless throughout life?” “And what about the objects being carried? Is not the situation the same?” “Of course.” “Now, if they were able to converse with one another, do you not think they would name these things that they are seeing?” “They must.” “What if the prison had an echo coming from the opposite wall? Whenever one of the passers-by spoke, do you think the men would believe the speaker to be anything other than the passing shadow?” “By Zeus, I do not,” he said.

^{515c}

“Then, such people would believe,” I said, “without reservation, that the truth is nothing but the shadows of the artificial objects.” “They really must,” he said. “Now,” I said, “consider what liberation from their bonds, and cure of their ignorance, would be like for them, if it happened naturally in the following way. Suppose one of them were released, and suddenly compelled to stand up, crane his neck, walk, and look up towards the light. Would ^{515d} he not be pained by all this, and on account of the brightness be unable to see the objects whose shadows he previously beheld? And if someone were to tell him that he beheld foolishness before, but now he sees more truly, since he is much closer to ‘what is’, and is turned towards things which partake of more being, what do you think he would say? Moreover, if they showed him each of the passing objects and

forced him to answer the question ‘what is this?’, do you not think he would be perplexed, and would believe that what he saw before was truer than what he is now being shown?” “Very much so,” he replied.

515e

“And if he were compelled to look towards the light itself, would not his eyes be pained? Would he not turn away and flee to those things he really can see, and regard these as, in fact, clearer than what he is being shown?” “Just so,” he replied.

516a

“And,” I said, “if someone were to drag him forcibly from there, along the rough upward path, and not let him go until he had been dragged out into the light of the sun, would he not be distressed and upset by the process? And once he had come into the light, would not his eyes be flooded with its glare, and be unable to see even one of what are now called truths.” “No, they would not,” he said. “Not immediately anyway.” “Yes, I think he would need to become accustomed to it if he were ever to behold the objects of the upper realm. At first he would discern shadows very easily, after that images of men and other objects in water, then the actual objects. From these he would proceed to view the heavenly bodies and the heaven itself by night, looking at the light of the stars and the moon more easily than the sun and the light of the sun by day.” “What else could he do?”

516b

“Then, I imagine, he would finally be able to behold the sun, not its appearance in water or in an alien setting, but just by itself, in its own place, and he would see the sun as it is.” “This must be so,” he said. “And after this, he would then make deductions about it, that this is what provides the seasons and the years, presiding over everything in the visible realm, and in a way the cause of everything they have been seeing.” “Obviously,” he said. “Those are the steps he would take.”

516c

“What then? Remembering his first dwelling place, and the wisdom there, and his former fellow prisoners, would he not believe that he himself was blessed by the transformation, and feel compassion for them?” “Very much so.”

516d

“And suppose they received certain honours and praises from one another, and there were privileges for whoever discerns the passing shadows most keenly, and is best at remembering which of them usually comes first or last, which are simultaneous, and on that basis is best able to predict what is going to happen next. Do you think he would have any desire for these prizes, or envy those who are honoured by the prisoners and hold power over them? Or would he much prefer the fate described by Homer and ‘work as a serf for a man with no land’,⁹⁹ and suffer anything at all, rather than hold their opinions and live as they do?” “I think it is just as you say. He would accept any fate rather than live as they do.”

516e

“Yes, and think about this,” I said. “If such a person were to go back down, and sit in the same seat, would not his eyes become filled with darkness after this sudden return from the sunlight?” “Very much so,” he said. “Now, suppose that he had to compete once more with those perpetual prisoners in recognising these shadows, while his eyesight was still poor, before his eyes had adjusted. Since it would take ^{517a} some time to become accustomed to the dark, would he not become a figure of fun? Would they not say that he went up, but came back down with his eyes ruined, and that it is not worth even trying to go upwards? And if they could somehow get their hands on and kill a person who was trying to free people and lead them upwards, would they not do just that?” “Definitely,” he said.

517b

“Then, dear Glaucon,” I said, “you should connect this image, in its entirety, with what we were saying before. Compare the realm revealed by sight to the prison house, and the firelight within it to the power of our sun. And if you suggest that the upward journey, and seeing the objects of the upper world, is the ascent of the soul to the realm known by reason, you will not be misreading my intention, since that is what you wanted to hear. God knows whether it happens to be true, but in any case this is how it all seems to me. When it comes to knowledge, the form of the good is ^{517c} seen last, and is seen only through effort. Once seen, it is reckoned to be the actual cause of all that is beautiful and right in everything, bringing to birth light, and the lord of light, in the visible realm, and providing truth and reason in the realm known by reason, where it is lord. Anyone who is to act intelligently, either in private or in public, must have had sight of this.” “I also hold the same views that you hold,” he said, “after my own fashion, anyway.”

^{517d}

“Come on, then,” I said, “and agree with me about something else. Do not be surprised that those who have attained these heights have no desire for involvement in human affairs. Their souls, rather, are constantly hastening to commune with the upper realm. For I presume that is what is likely to happen, if this really does accord with the image we described earlier.” “Yes, quite likely,” he said. “Yes. And do you think it would it be any surprise,” I asked, “if someone who has returned from divine contemplations to human affairs disgraces himself badly, and appears utterly ridiculous, while his eyes are still dim, and if, before he has become accustomed to the prevailing darkness, he is compelled to argue, in courtrooms or elsewhere, about the shadows of justice or the artificial ^{517e} objects which cast those shadows, and dispute about these matters as understood by people who have never seen justice itself?” “No, that would be no surprise at all,” he replied.

518a

“But if someone were endowed with reason,” I said, “he would recall that the confounding of the eyes is of two kinds and has two sources: a change from light to darkness, and from darkness to light. And having realised that the same thing happens to the soul, he will not laugh boorishly whenever he sees a soul confused and unable to see clearly. Instead, he will enquire whether it has come from a brighter life and is darkened because it is not used to the gloom, or it is coming from 518b the utter darkness of ignorance into a brighter realm, and is dazzled by the greater brilliance. So, on this basis he would regard the condition and the life of one soul as blessed, while he would feel compassion for the other. And if he wished to laugh at it, his laughter would be less scornful than it would for a soul descended from the light above.” “Yes,” he said. “What you are saying is very reasonable.”

518c

“Then,” I said, “if this is all true, there is something we need to recognise about it: education is not the sort of thing which some people profess it to be. They somehow claim that although knowledge is not present in the soul, they can put it there as if they were putting sight into blind eyes.” “Yes, that is what they say.” “Yes,” I said, “but the argument is now indicating that this capacity, present in the soul of each person, the instrument by which each learns, is like an eye which cannot turn to the light from the darkness unless the whole body turns. So, this instrument must be turned, along with the entire 518d soul, away from becoming until it becomes capable of enduring the contemplation of ‘what is’ and the very brightest of ‘what is’, which we call the good. Is this so?” “Yes.”

518e

“Then,” I said, “there would be a particular skill dealing with this turning of the soul, which will turn it around in the most easy and effective manner, a skill which does not produce sight

in the soul, but assumes that although sight is already present, it is not directed properly or looking where it should, and sets about correcting this.” “Yes, so it seems.”

519a

“Now, the other excellences, which are said to belong to the soul, are really somewhat closer to excellence of the body, for they are not actually present at first, but are generated later through habit and practice. However, that excellence wherein we employ reason surely belongs most of all to something more divine, it seems, something whose power is never destroyed, but becomes either useful and beneficial or useless and harmful, depending upon how the soul is turned. Or have you never noticed those men who are said to be evil and yet wise? Have you noticed the keen vision of their tiny soul, and how sharply it discerns whatever it happens to turn to? For there is no problem with its sight, but it is forced into the service of evil, and consequently the more keenly the soul sees, the more evil it accomplishes.” “Yes, certainly,” he said.

519b

“However,” I said, “if this part of one who possesses a nature of this kind is worked upon from earliest childhood, the relationships with becoming are cut away, as if they were leaden weights. These grow upon the soul through gluttony and similar pleasures, and the refinements thereof, and turn the vision of the soul downwards. But once the soul is quit of them, it turns around to the realm of truth, and the same part of the same people beholds that realm, just as clearly as it beholds whatever is in front of it now.” “Quite likely,” he said.

519c

“What about this? Is it not also likely,” I said, “and must it not follow from what we said before, that neither the uneducated, with no experience of truth, nor those who are allowed to spend all their time in education, would ever be adequate custodians of the city – the one, because they do not have a single purpose

in life which they should aim at in all the actions they perform in public or in private, and the other because they will not willingly engage in action, believing that whilst still alive they are already dwelling on the far-off Isles of the Blest?" "True," he said.

519d

"Now," I said, "it is our task as founders to compel the best natures to attain the learning which we said previously was the most important: to see the good, and ascend that upward path. And once they have ascended and seen enough, we must not allow them to do what is permitted at present." "What is that?" "They are allowed to remain there," I said, "with no desire to descend once more among those prisoners or to partake of their endeavours and their honours, whether these are mundane or more serious." "In that case," he said, "shall we be doing them an injustice? Shall we make them live an inferior life when a better one is available to them?"

519e

"My friend," I said, "you have just forgotten that the law is not concerned with how one particular class in the city may fare better than the others. Instead, it tries to bring this about in the city as a whole, creating harmony among the citizens by persuasion and compulsion, and making them share with one another any benefit that each of them is able to contribute to the community. And the law itself produces men like these in the city, not so that each may go in any direction he pleases, but to use them to bind the city together." "True," he said. "I had forgotten this."

520a

"Then," I said, "you must see, Glaucon, that we are not doing an injustice to the philosophers in our midst, but we shall be making just demands when we compel them to care for and protect the other citizens. We shall say that 'when people like you arise in the other cities, it is reasonable that 520b they do not

share in the labours of those cities. And this is justified there because such people develop of their own accord, through no intention on the part of that civic arrangement, and it is only fair that whatever develops of its own accord owes its nurture to no one, and should feel no urge to pay for that nurture. “But you have been bred by us like kings and rulers of the hive, both for your own sakes and for the rest of the city. Having been better and more perfectly educated than them, you are ^{520c} more capable of participating in both realms. Therefore, you must each play your part, and go down to where the others dwell together and become accustomed with them to the dark shadows. For once you are used to the darkness you will see a thousand times better than the people there. And you will know what each of the images is and what it is an image of, because you have seen the truth about things beautiful, just and good. Accordingly, the city will be governed by us and by you in a wakeful state, and not in a dream, as most cities are governed today by men who fight ^{520d} one another over shadows, and battle for public office as if that was the greatest good. But surely the truth is that the city in which those who are going to rule have the least desire to do so must be the best governed city and the one most free from strife. And if it gets the opposite sort of rulers, it must be ruled in the opposite manner.” “Yes, certainly,” he said. “Now, will our charges be unmoved when they hear this? And will they be reluctant to join in the work of the city when it is their turn, and then live together most of the time in the pure realm?”

^{520e}

“Impossible,” he replied. “We are laying just injunctions upon just men. However, each of them will approach public office very much as a necessity, in contrast to those who now rule each city.”

^{521a}

“So on this basis, my friend,” I said, “if you can find a better life than ruling for these who are going to rule, a well-governed city becomes a possibility for you. For only there will the truly wealthy be the rulers, wealthy not in gold but in the wealth which a blessed man needs – a good and reasonable life. However, if beggars, starved of goods of their own, enter public affairs thinking that therein they may seize the good, then it is an impossibility. For public office then becomes something to fight over, and a domestic and internal battle like this destroys the disputants and the rest of the city.” “Very true,” he said.

521b

“Now,” I said, “other than the life of true philosophy, can you think of any life that despises political office?” “By Zeus, I cannot,” he said. “Well, in that case, those who are not lovers of public office must take it on. Otherwise, the competing lovers will fight over it.” “How could it be otherwise?” “Now, are there any others whom you would compel to act as guardians of the city, others who would manage it better than those who are wisest about these matters, who have other honours and a better life than politics?” “There are no others,” he replied.

521c

“Then, would you like to go on to consider the manner in which people like this will arise in our city and how we shall lead them to the light, just as certain people are said to have ascended from Hades to the gods?” “How could I refuse?” he said. “Well this, it seems, would not be the mere flipping over of an oyster shell, but a process of turning the soul around from a day which is more like night, to the true day, the ascent to ‘what is’, an ascent which we may truly call philosophy.” “Yes, certainly.”

521d

“Then, is it necessary to consider which branch of learning possesses a power like this?” “It is necessary.”

521e

“Now, Glaucon, what subject would draw the soul from becoming towards ‘what is’? And something else occurs to me as I say this. Did we not state that these guardians must be practised in war when they are young?” “Yes, we said that.” “So, the subject we are looking for must also have this characteristic as well as the other.” “What characteristic?” “It must not be useless to military men.” “It certainly must not, if that is actually possible.” “In the earlier account they were educated by us in gymnastics and in music.” “They were,” he said. “Gymnastics is presumably concerned with what comes into being and passes away, for it presides over the development and the decline of the body.” “So it appears.” “Then this would not be the subject we are looking for.” “It would not.”

522a

“So in that case, is it music in the sense we described it earlier?” “But that was the counterpart of gymnastics,” he said. “And if you recall, it educated the guardians through habit, imparting gracefulness through its harmony, and orderliness through its rhythm, without imparting knowledge. And it also contained habits akin to these in its words, both in the mythical stories and in the truer versions. However, music does not include a branch of learning that leads towards the sort of thing you are looking for now.”

522b

“A most exact reminder,” I said, “for music actually contains nothing of that sort. But, my blessed Glaucon, what kind of subject would this be? Indeed all of the skills seemed somehow to be mechanical.” “Yes, they must be. And yet what other subject is left apart from music, gymnastics and the various skills?” “Come on,” I said. “If we cannot come up with anything besides these, let us select something applicable to them all.” “Like what?” “Like this, what they have in common, that which all skills, thoughts and knowledge refer to, and which is also the first thing everyone needs to learn.” “What is it?” he asked.

522c

"The ordinary process," I said, "of distinguishing one, two and three; in short, arithmetic and calculation. Is it not the case that all skill and knowledge needs to involve recourse to these?" "Very much so," he replied. "Military skill too?" I asked. "It certainly must," he replied.

522d

"In that case, Palamedes in the tragedies repeatedly shows up Agamemnon as an utterly ridiculous general.¹⁰⁰ Or have you not noticed that he claims to have discovered number, and arranged the ranks of the army at Troy, counted the ships, and everything else, as though they had not been counted before? And apparently Agamemnon did not know how many feet he had since he did not know how to count. So what sort of general do you think he was?" "A strange one," he replied, "if this is true."

522e

"So," I said, "should we propose that the ability to calculate and count is a necessary branch of learning for a military man?" "It is the most necessary of all," he said, "if he is going to have any understanding whatsoever of arranging armies, and more importantly if he is even to be human." "Now, do you notice what I notice about this subject?" "What is that?"

523a

"It is quite likely to be one of the subjects we are seeking, which, by nature, leads us towards reason. However, no one uses it correctly, that is, as a subject which can draw one comprehensively towards being." "How do you mean?" he said. "Well, I shall try to set out my opinion," I said. "Look at this with me, and agree or disagree so that we may see more clearly if my suspicion is correct. For I am distinguishing for myself between what leads and what does not lead in the direction we spoke of." "Give an example," he said.

523b

“Take this example,” I said. “Observe, if you can, that in the case of sense perceptions, there are some which do not call upon reason to investigate them since they are adequately judged by the senses. Others, however, completely depend upon reason to investigate them, since the senses furnish nothing trustworthy.” “You are obviously referring to distant phenomena and to shadow-drawing,” he said. “You have not really got my meaning,” I said. “Then what do you mean?” he asked.

523c

“Those which do not call upon reason are those which do not extend into the opposite sensation at the same time. However, in the case of those which do extend, I suggest that they call upon reason whenever the sense impression reveals something, no more than its opposite, regardless of whether it impinges upon us from near or far. My meaning will be clearer from this example. We would say that these are three fingers, the smallest, the second and the middle.” “Certainly,” he said. “Assume that I am describing them as seen from close up. Now, there is a question you must consider in relation to them.” “What is it?”

523d

“Well, each of them, in the same way, appears to be a finger, and in this respect there is no difference, whether it is seen in the middle or at either extreme, whether it is white or black, or whether it is fat or thin, or anything of that sort. For in all these cases, the soul of most people is not compelled to put a question to reason as to what precisely a finger is. For at no stage does sight indicate to the soul that the finger is the opposite of a finger at the same time.” “No, it does not,” he said. “Therefore,” I said, “a case such as this would be unlikely to call upon or awaken reason.” “Unlikely.”

523e

“What about this? Does sight see their largeness or smallness adequately, and does it make no difference to sight whether one of them lies in the middle or on either side? Does the same apply to thickness and thinness, and hardness and softness in the case of touch? And do the other senses ^{524a} reveal things like this without any deficiency? Or does each of them behave in the following manner: the sense which extends to hard must also extend to soft, and it proclaims to the soul that the same thing is being perceived as both hard and soft?” “Just so,” he replied. “Must not the soul,” I said, “for its part, be perplexed in such circumstances, as to what precisely the hard that the particular sense is indicating actually is, since it also says that the same thing is soft. And if the sense of light and heavy indicates that heavy is light and light is heavy, must not the soul be perplexed as to what is heavy and what is light?” “Yes, indeed,” he replied. “These messages to the soul are strange and require further investigation.”

^{524b}

“So,” I said, “it is likely that in these situations the soul first calls upon calculation and reason, and tries to investigate whether each of the proclamations is two or one.” “Yes, what else could it do?” “If it turns out that it is two, would not each of the two appear to be both different and one?” “Yes.” “So, if each is one and both are two, soul will recognise the two as separate, for if they were not separate it would not have recognised two, but only one.” “Correct.” “And we say sight too has seen large and small, not separately however, but in combination. Is this so?” “Yes.”

^{524c}

“But for the sake of clarity in this, reason, in contrast to sight, is compelled to view large and small, not mixed together but separately.” “True.” “Hence, the first thing that occurs to us is to ask what precisely ‘large’ and ‘small’ actually are. Is this not so?” “Entirely so.” “And on this basis, of course, we said there

was a realm known by reason, and also a realm known by sight.”
“You are perfectly right.”

524d

“Well, this is what I was trying to explain earlier, that there are some things that call upon thought, and others that do not. Now, I define those things that impinge upon the sense at the same time as their own opposites as provoking reason, while those which do not do this do not awaken reason.” “Very well, I understand now,” he said, “and I think this is right.” “Well then, to which realm do you think number and the one belong?” “I cannot decide,” he replied.

524e

“But you can work it out from what was said before,” I said. “If the one is seen adequately just by itself, or apprehended by some other sense, it would be like the finger we referred to and would not draw people towards being. However, if the one is always seen along with something which is opposite to it, so that what is presented is no more one than its opposite, discrimination would then be required. And in that situation, the soul, activating the intelligence within itself, would have to be perplexed, and search, and ask, ‘What precisely is the one itself?’ And accordingly, getting knowledge of the one would be among the branches of learning that lead the soul, and turn it around towards the contemplation of ‘what is’.” “And, indeed,” he said, “this applies in no less measure to seeing it, for we see the same thing both as one, and as an unlimited multiplicity, at the same time.”

525a

“Since this is what happens in the case of the one,” said I, “will not the same thing happen with all number?” “It must.” “And, indeed, calculation and arithmetic are entirely concerned with number.” “Very much so.” “Yes, and these appear to lead towards truth.” “Yes, to an enormous extent.” “So apparently, these would be among the subjects we are seeking. For a

military man must learn them in order to arrange an army in ranks, and a philosopher has to learn them too, because he ^{525b} must lay hold of being and rise out of becoming, otherwise he will never be able to calculate.” “This is the case,” he replied. “Now, our guardian turns out to be both a military man and a philosopher.” “Of course.”

525c

“In that case, Glaucon, it would be appropriate to establish this subject by law, and persuade those who are going to participate in the most important affairs of the city to have recourse to calculation, and take it up not as a personal matter, but until they attain the contemplation of the nature of the numbers by means of reason itself. They should not practise it for the sake of buying and selling, like merchants or retailers, but for the sake of war, and the ready turning of the soul itself away from becoming, towards truth and being.” “That is beautifully expressed,” he said.

525d

“And, indeed,” I said, “in the light of what is being said about the subject of calculation, I realise that it is nicely and entirely suited to our purpose, provided it is pursued for the sake of knowledge and not for shop-keeping.” “In what way then?” he asked. “In the way we already described. It leads the soul powerfully upwards to some place, and compels it to engage in dialectic in relation to the numbers themselves. It will not accept it at all if someone presents the soul with numbers associated with visible or tangible things, and discusses them. For ^{525e} I presume you know that its skilled exponents are amused if anyone, in discussion, attempts to divide the one itself, and they will not accept this. If you divide it, they will multiply, being careful lest the one ever proves to be not one, but a multiplicity of parts.” “What you are saying is very true,” he said.

526a

“Glaucón, if someone were to ask them, ‘Wonderful men, what sort of numbers are you talking about in which the one is as you are proposing, each in every case equal to each, not the slightest bit different, and having no parts within itself?’ What do you think their reply would be?” “I think they would say that they are referring to those numbers which it is possible to grasp only by thought, and which it is not possible to deal with in any other way at all.”

526b

“Now, my friend,” I said, “do you see that in truth this is likely to be the subject we require, since it evidently compels the soul to resort to reason itself, for the sake of truth itself?” “Yes, indeed,” he said. “It certainly does that.” “Well then, have you ever considered the fact that those who take naturally to calculation are said to be bright in all subjects? While those who are dull, if they are educated and exercised in this subject, all improve and become brighter than they were before, even if they derive no other benefit?” “That is the way it is,” he replied.

526c

“And indeed, in my view, you would not easily find many subjects which involve greater toil in learning or in practising than this one.” “Indeed not.” “So for all these reasons, the subject must not be dismissed, and the best natures must be educated in it.” “I agree,” he said. “Then let us leave it at that, and consider whether the second subject, the one that follows it, is appropriate to our purpose.” “What sort of subject?” he asked. “Do you mean geometry?” “The very one,” I replied.

526d

“Insofar as it is applicable to military affairs, it will obviously be appropriate,” he said. “Indeed, the man who knows geometry would be superior to one who does not in setting up camp, capturing territory, drawing the army into close formation or dispersing it, and in any other arrangements of the army in the battle itself or on a march.”

526e

“But, of course,” said I, “even a little geometry and calculation would be sufficient for these purposes. But we need to consider whether most of it, and the more advanced part thereof, is inclined to make the form of the good easier to discern. That is the objective. And according to us, any subject inclines to this, provided it compels the soul to turn around to that place where the most blessed part of ‘what is’ resides, a part that the soul must behold in every way.” “Correct,” said he. “And in that case, if it compels the soul to behold being, it is an appropriate subject. But if it compels it to behold becoming, it is not appropriate.” “Yes, so we say.”

527a

“Well,” said I, “no one with even the slightest experience of geometry will argue with us over this proposition, that this knowledge itself stands in total contrast to what is said about it in discussion by those who practise it.” “How so?” said he. “Well, they somehow speak quite comically, and they are actually compelled to do so. In fact, by using terms like ‘squaring’ and ‘applying’ and ‘extending’, and so on, they speak as though they are engaging in activity and as if they are constructing arguments for some practical purpose, even though, I presume, the entire subject is pursued for the sake of knowledge.” “Yes, entirely so,” he said.

527b

“Can we agree on a further point?” “What is it?” “They pursue it for the sake of knowledge of ‘what always is’, and not of what becomes something at some time and is then destroyed.” “That is easy to accept,” said he. “Geometrical knowledge is knowledge of what always is.” “So, my noble friend, it would be a subject that draws the soul towards truth and produces a philosophic mind, directing upwards whatever we now, incorrectly, direct downwards.” “Yes, as best it can,” said he.

527c

“So,” said I, “you must arrange, as best you can, that the people in ‘Noble-City’ do not refrain from geometry in any way, for even its incidental benefits are significant.” “What are they?” he asked. “Those you mentioned,” said I, “those concerned with warfare. And of course we know, I presume, that for any subject to be better assimilated, it generally makes all the difference whether the student has already taken to geometry or not.” “All the difference indeed, by Zeus,” said he. “So, should we propose this as the second subject for our young folk?” “We should.”

527d

“What about this? Should we propose astronomy as a third subject? Or do you not think we should?” “I do, indeed,” said he. “For being better able to discern the seasons, the months and the years is appropriate, not only for agriculture and navigation, but also for generalship, no less.”

527e

“You amuse me,” said I. “You seem to be afraid of what most people may think of you if you prescribe impractical subjects. It is no ordinary matter; in fact, it is quite difficult to be convinced that some organ of the soul, an organ that everyone has, is purified and rekindled by these studies, having been corrupted and blinded by our other pursuits, and that it is more important to preserve this organ than it is to preserve ten thousand eyes. For truth is seen only by this. Now, those who hold these opinions already will think that what you are saying is really sound, while those with no awareness of this at all are likely to think you are talking nonsense, for they will see no other benefit worth mentioning from these. So decide here and now which group you are conversing ^{528a} with, if any. Or perhaps you are formulating the arguments mainly for your own sake, although you would not, of course, begrudge anyone else who might derive some benefit from them.” “That is my choice,” said he. “I am speaking, asking questions and answering them, mostly for my own sake.” “Let us fall back then,” said I, “since

we did not pick the subject that comes next after geometry correctly just now.” “How did we go wrong?” he asked.

528b

“After flat surfaces,” I said, “we took solids already in rotation before taking solids just by themselves. The correct sequence is to take the third dimension after the second, and this is presumably the dimension associated with cubes, and whatever has depth.” “Quite so, Socrates,” he said, “but these do not seem to have been found yet.” “Yes,” said I, “for two reasons. Firstly, because no city affords them proper respect, these matters, being so difficult, are not thoroughly investigated. Secondly, investigators in this area need a guide, without whom they will not discover anything. But a guide is hard to find in the first place, and 528c when found, as matters now stand, the arrogant fellows who would be able to investigate this would pay no heed to him. But if an entire city were to co-operate with the guide by treating these matters with respect, these people would heed him, and under close and intensive investigation the true state of affairs would become evident. Even now, although they are disrespected and criticised by most people, and by those who investigate them without being able to explain their usefulness, nevertheless, in the face of all this they develop by force, due to their inherent charm, and it would be no surprise if they were to come to light.”

528d

“Yes, indeed,” said he. “They do possess exceptional charm. But explain what you are saying more clearly, for I presume you designated the study of flat surfaces as geometry.” “Yes,” said I. “Then,” said he, “initially you put astronomy after that, but later on you changed your mind.” “Yes,” said I. “In my haste to recount everything quickly I am making slower progress. For, although the study of the dimension of depth is next in sequence, I passed over this because of the comical state of the investigation, and after geometry I spoke of astronomy, which is

the motion of objects with depth.” “Right,” said he.

528e

“Then, provided the city pursues it, let us propose astronomy as the fourth subject, on the assumption that the third, the one we are now passing over, exists.” “Quite likely,” said he. “And I will now praise astronomy, Socrates, in the way you set about it, and avoid the commonplace manner of praise for which you rebuked me. Indeed, ^{529a} it is obvious to everyone that this study compels the soul to look upwards, and leads it away from what is here to what is there, above.” “This is probably obvious to everyone except me,” said I, “since that is not how it seems to me.” “How does it seem to you?” he asked. “Handled, as it is nowadays, by those who are elevating us towards philosophy, it really makes the soul look downwards.” “How do you mean?” he asked.

529b

“I think you have a very liberal understanding of the subject concerned with the upper realm,” I said. “Indeed, if someone were to throw his head back and contemplate adornments on the ceiling and arrive at some understanding, you would probably think he was contemplating them with his intellect rather than his eyes. Now, perhaps your thinking is sound and I am being simple-minded, for I cannot think of anything that makes the soul look to the upper realm except the subject that is concerned with ‘what is’ and the unseen. Whether someone attempts to understand sense objects by gaping upwards or squinting downwards, I would never maintain that he has ever understood ^{529c} anything. For things of this sort do not admit of knowledge, and his soul is not gazing upwards but downwards even if he tries to understand while floating on his back, on land or in the sea.” “I am getting my just deserts,” said he, “and you are right to rebuke me. But in what way are you saying astronomy should be studied, contrary to the way they study it nowadays, if its study is to confer the benefits we are speaking

of?” “As follows,” said I. “These adornments that are in the heavens adorn in the visible realm, and although they should be regarded as the most beautiful and perfect of visible objects, they do fall far short of the true adornments, the motions with which actual speed and actual slowness are moved with respect to one another in the true number and in all the true shapes, carrying whatever they contain. These can be apprehended by reason and by thought, but not by sight. Or do you think otherwise?” “Not at all,” he replied.

529d

“Therefore,” said I, “we must use the heavenly adornments as patterns in order to understand what is unseen, just as if we had come across diagrams, exceptionally well drawn and executed by ^{529e} Daedalus,¹⁰¹ or some other craftsman or draughtsman. For anyone experienced in geometry, on seeing this sort of thing, would surely think that although the workmanship is very beautiful, it would be quite ridiculous to scrutinise them seriously with a view to finding the truth about equals, or doubles, or any other proportion, in these.” “Yes, it must be ridiculous,” said he.

530a

“Do you not think, then,” I asked, “that the genuine astronomer will come to the same conclusion when he looks upon the motions of the stars? Will he not be of the opinion that these, and whatever they contain, have been fashioned in the most beautiful manner possible for objects of this sort by the craftsman of the heaven? But what about the proportion of night to day, of these to the month, of the month to the year, and of the other stars to these and to one another? Well, do you not believe the true astronomer will think it strange if anyone regards these as unchanging and as undergoing no alteration whatsoever, even though they are physical objects and are visible; and if someone seeks in various ways to grasp the truth about these?” “Well, I think so now at any rate,” said he, “now

that I hear you saying so.”

530b

“So,” said I, “we should engage in astronomy by making use of problems, just as we do in geometry, and bid farewell to the heavenly bodies, if we are actually going to engage in astronomy, so as to make the intelligence that is naturally present in the soul useful rather than useless.” “You are prescribing a task,” said he, “that is very much larger than what astronomy deals with nowadays.” “I think,” said I, “that our other prescriptions will be of the same sort if we are to be of any use as lawgivers. But anyway, do you have any other appropriate subject to suggest?” “I do not have any,” said he, “not immediately at any rate.”

530c

“Well,” said I, “motion, in my opinion, does not consist of one form only, but of many. Now, a wise man could perhaps list them all, but two are evident, even to us.” “What are they?” “Besides this one, astronomy, there is the counterpart of this.” “Which is?”

530d

“It is quite likely,” said I, “that just as the eyes have been framed for astronomy, so too were the ears framed for harmonic motion, and that these two branches of knowledge are kindred to one another, as the Pythagoreans maintain. And we are agreeing with them, Glaucon. Is that what we are doing?” “Just so,” he replied.

530e

“Therefore,” said I, “since this is a considerable task, we shall find out from them what they have to say on these matters, and whether there is anything else besides these. But throughout the entire process we shall guard our own concern.” “Which is?” “That our charges should never attempt to learn anything incomplete, anything that does not consistently reach the point which everything needs to reach, a failing we ascribed earlier to

astronomy.

531a

Or do you not know that in the case of harmony, too, the practitioners do something similar? Indeed, for their part, they measure the concords and sounds that are heard, against one another, engaging in useless labour, just like the astronomers.” “Yes, by the gods,” said he. “And they call some intervals ‘dense’, bending their ears towards them as if they were eavesdropping on their neighbours, some declaring that they still hear a note in between, and that this is the smallest interval by which we should measure, while others dispute this and say it is the same as the note already sounding, both parties 531b granting their ears priority over their intelligence.” “You are referring,” said I, “to the good fellows who inflict trouble upon the strings, and torture them by tightening them upon the pegs. But in case this image gets out of hand I will put a stop to it now, before it refers to the strings being beaten with the plectrum, the various accusations against them, and their reluctance or readiness to answer. These are not the people I am referring to, but the others, those we said just now we would ask about harmony. Indeed, these fellows do the same 531c thing as those who are involved in astronomy since they are looking for numbers in the concords that they can hear, and they do not ascend to the level of problems and investigate which numbers are concordant and which are not, and the reason why this is so.” “The task you are describing,” said he, “is not of this world.” “Well,” said I, “it is useful if it is done in search of the beautiful and the good; otherwise it is useless.” “Quite likely,” said he.

531d

“And I also think,” said I, “that if the method we have described for all these subjects gets to their kinship and what they have in common, and works out their mutual affinities, then their pursuit does contribute something to our desired ends and is

not unprofitable; otherwise it is pointless.” “And I feel the same way, Socrates,” said he. “But you are describing an enormous undertaking.” “Are you speaking of the prelude,” said I, “or what? Or do we not know that these are all a prelude to the main theme, the one that we must learn? For you surely do not think that those who are clever in these subjects are skilled in dialectic.”

531e

“By Zeus, I do not,” said he, “apart from a few exceptions I have come across.” “Well, then,” said I, “do you think those who are unable to present an argument, and respond to one, will ever know anything of what we say they must know?” “In that case, too,” said he, “the answer is no.”

532a

“Glaucón,” said I, “is not this, at last, the main theme, the very one that dialectic performs? And although it is known by reason, it would imitate the power of sight that we described in our earlier image, which at a certain stage tries to look at the actual living creatures, then at the stars themselves, and finally at the sun itself. And whenever someone attempts in this way, by dialectic, without any of the senses, to get to what each thing itself is, through reason, and does not give up until he apprehends what the good itself is, by the reasoning process itself, he then arrives at the end of 532b the realm known by reason, just as the other man in our allegory came to the end of the visible realm.” “Entirely so,” said he.

532c

“Yes, and do you not refer to this process as dialectical?” “Indeed.” “And what about the release of the prisoner from his bonds, his turning from the shadows to the images that cast them, and to the light, the ascent from underground into the sunlight, and his inability when he gets there to look yet at the actual animals and plants and the light of the sun, and his looking instead at divine appearances in water, or at shadows of

things that are, rather than the shadows of images, cast by another such light which, when compared to the sun, is like another shadow? All this practice of the subjects we have described has this power, and leads what is best in the soul upwards to the sight of what is most excellent among things that are, just as in our allegory what is brightest in the body was led upwards towards the sight of what is most resplendent in the realm of the physical and visible.”

532d

“I accept,” said he, “that this is so. And yet, although I find it extremely difficult to accept, in another way it is difficult not to. Nevertheless, this needs to be heard often, not only today, but in future, so we should return to this. But let us assume for now that what has been proposed is indeed so, and then proceed to the main theme itself and go through it in detail, just as we did with the prelude. So tell me, what is the manner of this power of dialectic, what sort of forms is it divided into, and what paths does it follow? For these would be the ones that lead at last to where there is, for whoever gets there, a sort of rest from the journey and an end to the process.”

532e

“Dear Glaucon,” said I, “you will not be able to follow me any longer, even though there will not be any lack of eagerness on my part. Nor would you still be seeing an image of what we are speaking of, but the truth itself, as it appears to me anyway. At the moment it is not right to insist that this is actually so, or that it is not. But we should insist that there is something of this sort to be seen. Is this so?” “Of course.” “And should we not also insist that the power of dialectic alone would reveal this to someone with experience in what we have been describing just now, and that this is not possible in any other way?” “It is only right,” said he, “that we insist upon this too.”

533a

“Well,” said I, “no one will argue against us when we say that some other method, apart from the five subjects, attempts to grasp systematically, in each and every case, what each itself is. But all the other skills are concerned with people’s opinions and desires, or with producing things or assembling them, or with looking after them once they have been produced or assembled. As for the rest, geometry and so on, we maintained that these apprehended something of what is. But we ^{533b} see that although they dream about what is, they are unable to see it, wide awake, as long as they make use of hypotheses that are left unchallenged because they are unable to give an account of them. For when the first principle is something that is not known, and the conclusion and everything in between is woven from what is not known, is there any way that a combination like this could ever constitute knowledge?” “None at all,” said he.

^{533c}

“Does not the dialectical method alone,” said I, “proceed in this way to the first principle itself by doing away with hypotheses in order to be sure of its ground? It draws the eye of the soul, which is actually buried in some outlandish mire, and leads it upwards, using the very subjects we have described as helpmates and assistants in the conversion. We have often referred to these subjects as branches of knowledge out of habit, but they need another name to indicate greater clarity than opinion, and more vagueness than knowledge. I think we used ‘understanding’ to make the distinction earlier, but in my opinion there is no point in arguing over a name, when an enquiry into such important matters lies before us.”

^{533d}

“No, indeed,” he replied.

^{533e}

“So,” said I, “are you content to do what we did before and call the first part knowledge, the second ^{534a} understanding, the

third belief, and the fourth imagination? The last two, both together, constitute opinion; the first two, intelligence. Opinion is concerned with becoming, while intelligence is concerned with being. And as being is to becoming so is intelligence to opinion, and as intelligence is to opinion so is knowledge to belief, and understanding to imagination. “But the proportion between what these two are directed towards, Glaucon, and the twofold division of each of these – what is grasped by opinion and what is grasped by intelligence – this we should leave aside in case we get involved in many times more arguments than we have already been through.”

534b

“Well,” said he, “insofar as I am able to follow, I agree with you about the others.” “And do you describe someone who acquires an account of the being of each thing as dialectical? And would you not say that someone who cannot do so, insofar as he is unable to give an account, either to himself or to anyone else, lacks intelligence about the thing to that extent?” “How could I say otherwise?” he replied.

534c

“Does not the same also apply to the good? If someone is not able to separate the form of the good by argument – setting it apart from everything else, going through all the refutations like a warrior, eager to practise refutation based upon being rather than opinion, and coming through all this with his argument still standing – you will say, will you not, that someone who cannot do this does not know the good itself, nor any other good either? And if he does, somehow, get hold of some image of the good, he does so by opinion and not by knowledge? He is dreaming and sleeping this life ^{534d} away, and before he ever wakes up here, he arrives finally in Hades and sleeps on forever. Is this not what you would say?” “Yes, by Zeus,” said he. “I’d say all that, very much so.” “But of course in the case of your own children, whom you are bringing up and

educating in our discussion, if you were ever actually bringing them up, I presume you would not allow them to be irrational, like lines in geometry, when ruling the city and presiding over matters of the utmost importance.” “Indeed not,” said he. “Then will you pass a law by which they receive an education that enables them, above all, to ask and answer questions in the most knowledgeable manner possible?”

534e

“I shall, indeed,” said he, “with your help.”

535a

“In that case,” said I, “do you think we now have dialectic positioned above the other subjects, like a coping stone, that no other subject may rightly be placed higher, and that our discussion of the various subjects is now complete?” “I do, indeed,” said he. “Well,” said I, “your remaining task is their distribution and deciding to whom we shall allocate these subjects, and in what way.” “Of course,” said he. “Do you remember the kind of people we chose when we selected our rulers earlier?” “How could I forget?” said he.

535b

“Well, in general,” said I, “those very natures are the ones that must be selected. The most steadfast and the bravest should be chosen, and, as far as possible, the most comely. As well as this, we must look not only for those who are noble and virile in character, but they should also have the natural qualities suited to this particular education.” “What qualities?” “They need to be keen, my friend, on the subjects they learn, and have no difficulty in understanding them. Indeed, men’s souls are much more inclined to turn coward in the face of demanding ^{535c} studies than in the gymnasium, since the exertion is more personal to themselves because it is private and not shared with the body.” “True,” said he. “Well, we should look for good memory, robustness, and a total love of hard work. Or how else do you think anyone would be prepared to undertake the

physical labour and also complete so much study and practice?" "No one would," said he, "not unless he was extraordinarily gifted by nature."

535d

"Our current problem," said I, "and the associated disrespect for philosophy, has come about because, as I said before, those who take to philosophy are unworthy of it. What philosophy needs are genuine adherents, not fakes." "In what way?" he asked. "Firstly," said I, "someone who takes to philosophy should not be handicapped in his love of hard work so that he loves half the work and does not bother with the other half. This happens when someone loves exercise and loves hunting and loves all physical labour but is not a lover of learning, does not like to listen, has no spirit of enquiry, and hates any work that involves any of these. And when the situation is reversed, the man's love of labour is handicapped in the opposite way." "Very true," said he.

535e

"And will we not suggest," said I, "that a soul is maimed in relation to truth in the same way if it hates the deliberate lie, finds it unbearable in itself, and gets extremely angry when lied to by others and yet calmly accepts the unintentional lie, is untroubled by the lack of understanding when caught out somehow, and has no qualms about being debased in ignorance like some swinish beast?" "Yes, entirely so," said he.

536a

"And when it comes to sound-mindedness, courage, magnanimity, and all the other parts of excellence," said I, "must we not be on our guard just as much to distinguish between the genuine and the fake? For whenever a city or an individual does not know how to look at things like this comprehensively, they unwittingly rely on fakes or those whose work is handicapped as their allies or rulers as the case may be." "That is what happens," said he, "very much so."

536b

“Then, we should be extremely careful about everything of this sort,” said I, “because if we introduce sensible people, sound of body, to such extensive study and exercise, and educate them, justice itself will find no fault with us and we shall save our city and its form of government. But if we introduce people of the wrong sort to these studies, we shall achieve the complete opposite, and deluge philosophy with even more ridicule.” “That, indeed,” said he, “would be shameful.”

536c

“It certainly would,” said I. “But at the moment, I too seem to be inviting ridicule.” “How so?” said he. “I forgot,” said I, “that we were just playing, and I spoke with too much intensity. For as I was speaking I turned my gaze towards philosophy, and seeing it being trampled undeservedly in the mire, I think I went into a rage and said what I said too seriously, as though I were angry with those responsible.” “By Zeus, no,” said he. “That is not how it sounded to me as I listened.”

536d

“Well,” said I, “that is how it sounded to me as I said it. But we must not forget that in the previous selection process we picked old men, but in this case that is not allowed. Indeed, we should not believe Solon,¹⁰² that a person is able to learn a lot in old age. He can no more learn than run a race! No, all great labours, and there are many, belong to the young.” “They must,” said he.

536e

“Now, calculation, geometry, and all the preliminary instruction that should precede education in dialectic, needs to be set before them when they are still children, without presenting it in the form of compulsory instruction that they must learn.” “Why not?” “Because,” said I, “a free man should never learn any subject under conditions of slavery. Indeed, physical labours performed under compulsion do not make the body any worse, but no instruction, forcibly imparted, is

retained by the soul.” “True,” said he.

537a

“So, my friend,” said I, “as you bring up the children in these various subjects, do not do it forcibly, but playfully, so that you will be better able to discern what each of them is naturally adapted to.” “That sounds reasonable,” said he. “Do you not remember,” said I, “that, assuming it was safe to do so, we also maintained that the children should be brought to the battlefield on horseback, as spectators, and brought close to the fray to get a taste of blood like young hunting dogs?” “I remember,” said he. “And in all these exertions, studies, and dangers,” said I, “whoever should prove consistently to be most adept is to be admitted to a select number.” “At what age?” he asked.

537b

“At the time,” said I, “when their compulsory gymnastics comes to an end. For during that period of about two or three years, it is impossible to undertake anything else, since tiredness and sleep are inimical to study. And at the same time, their prowess in gymnastics is in itself one of their most important tests.” “Yes,” said he, “it would have to be.” “And when this period is over,” said I, “those twenty-year-olds who have been selected will have ^{537c} to bring the subjects that were presented unsystematically during their childhood education into a combined view of the interrelatedness of the subjects with one another, and with the nature of ‘what is’.” “Yes,” said he, “only this sort of learning becomes steadfast in those who receive it.” “And this,” said I, “is the greatest test of whether their natures are dialectical or not; someone who can take a combined view is dialectical, while someone who cannot do so is not.” “I concur,” said he.

537d

“Well,” said I, “you will need to consider all this. Those among our young folk who are most like these people and are also

reliable in their studies, in war, and in their other appointed duties, these again, once they reach thirty, should be selected from among the previous selection and awarded even greater honour. You should then see, testing them by the power of dialectic, who is able to let go the eyes and the other senses, and proceed in the company of truth to what just 'is'. And here, my friend, the task requires the utmost care." "Why exactly?" said he.

537e

"Are you not aware," said I, "of how much harm is done by dialectic as it is practised nowadays?" "What sort of harm?" he asked. "Its practitioners," said I, "are filled with lawlessness." "Very much so," said he. "Now," said I, "do you think it is any surprise that this happens to them, and do you not sympathise with them?" "In what way exactly?" he asked.

538a

"Suppose," said I, "that a changeling child was brought up amidst great wealth, in a large and extensive family, surrounded by lots of flatterers. What if he became aware as a grown man that he was not related to these so-called parents and was unable to find his real parents? Can you guess what his attitude would be towards those flatterers and the substitute parents, either during the time when he did not know about the switch, or later when he did know? Or would you like to hear my guess?" "I would like that," said he.

538b

"Well," said I, "my guess is that during the time when he did not know the truth, he would honour his father and mother and his other supposed family members more than those who flatter him. He would be less inclined to allow them to want for anything or to do or say anything unlawful to them, and more inclined to be persuaded by them rather than by the flatterers on important matters." "Quite likely," said he.

538c

“But once he had become aware of the actual situation, my guess is that, in contrast, he would lose his honour and respect for them, intensify his respect for the flatterers, and be persuaded by them to a greater extent than before. He would then live as they do, associate openly with them, and pay no heed to that pretended father and the rest of his pretended relatives, unless he was extremely reasonable by nature.” “Everything you are describing,” said he, “is the sort of thing that would actually happen. But what relevance does this image have for those who are encountering dialectic?” “As follows. There are, I presume, certain doctrines about what is just and beautiful that we have from childhood, doctrines we have been brought up on, so that we grant them authority and honour them like parents.” “There are indeed.”

538d

“And there are pursuits, opposed to these doctrines, pursuits that involve pleasure which flatter this soul of ours and drag it in their direction. However, these do not sway people who have some element of measure, who continue to honour the traditional doctrines and grant them authority.” “That is right.” “What about this?” said I. “Suppose there comes a time when someone in such a situation is faced with a question and asked, ‘What is the beautiful?’, and he gives the answer he heard from the conventional source, but the argument refutes this. Suppose it refutes him many times in lots of different ways, and reduces him to the opinion that this is no more beautiful than it is ugly, and the same thing happens with the just, the good, and whatever is held in the highest esteem. How do you think he will behave after this towards those doctrines in terms of honour and granting them authority?” “Inevitably,” said he, “he will no longer honour them in the same way, or be persuaded by them either.”

538e

“Now,” said I, “when he regards these doctrines as no longer worthy of the honour he gave them before, and has no affinity with them, but cannot discover the true ones, is he likely to have recourse to any other life besides the flatterer’s life?” “He is not,” said he. “In that case, I think, he will seem to have become lawless, having previously been law abiding.” “He must.”

539a

“Is this not,” said I, “the likely predicament of those who encounter dialectic in this way and who, as I said earlier, deserve a lot of sympathy?” “Yes,” said he, “and pity too.” “Well, should you not be careful with every detail of their encounter with dialectic so that there is no need to pity your thirty-year-old students?” “Very much so,” said he.

539b

“So, there is one thing to be extremely careful about, is there not? That they do not get a taste of this when they are still young. For I presume you have noticed that youngsters, when they first get a taste of dialectic, misuse it as if it was their plaything, by using it always to come up with counter-arguments. They themselves imitate those who engage in refutation by refuting other people, taking delight, like puppies, in verbally tugging at and pulling apart anyone who ever comes near them.” “Exceedingly so,” said he.

539c

“And so, when they themselves have refuted many, and have been refuted by many, they descend rapidly and inexorably to a state where they believe nothing they believed before, and, as a consequence, they themselves, and philosophy in general, are held in low regard by everyone else.” “Very true,” he said. “But someone older,” said I, “would not want to be involved in such madness. He will imitate the one who is willing to engage in dialectic and consider the truth rather than the one who plays with ^{539d} it for fun and just argues against people. And he himself

will be more measured and will bring honour to this activity rather than dishonour.” “That is right,” said he. “Now, was not everything that was said previous to this said as a caution? That dialectic is to be imparted to the orderly and stable natures, and not, as is done nowadays, to anyone at all, even if they are unsuited.” “Yes, certainly,” said he.

539e

“Is it enough then to persist with the practice of dialectic continuously and intensively, without any involvement in anything else, as a mental counterpart of the bodily exercises they practised for twice as many years as that?” “Do you mean six years or four?” he asked. “It does not matter,” said I. “Let us suggest five. For after this they will be brought down again into that cave, and compelled to rule over military matters and take up other positions of authority suited to the young so that they do not lag behind the others in experience. And in these situations, ^{540a} too, they will still be tested to see if they hold firm or shift their ground when they are being dragged in all directions.” “How much time,” he asked, “are you proposing for this?” “Fifteen years,” said I. “And when they have turned fifty, those who have come through safely and have excelled in every way at everything, in action and in knowledge, should be led at that stage to the final destination. They should be compelled to lift the ray of the soul upwards to behold that which provides light to everything, and, seeing the good itself and using that as their pattern, ^{540b} bring order to the city, its citizens and themselves, for the rest of their lives. Each in turn should spend most of their time in philosophy. But when their turn comes, they should get involved in the drudgery of civic affairs, each exercising authority for the sake of the city, doing so not as some fine activity but as a necessity. And having continually educated others in this way, others who are like themselves, and having left these behind as guardians of the city, they themselves depart to the Isles of the Blest to dwell there. And

the city should have memorials to them and ^{540c} offer sacrifices publicly, as if to demigods, if the Pythia consents, and if not, as to blessed or divine personages.” “You are like a sculptor, Socrates,” said he, “fashioning rulers who are absolutely beautiful.” “Female rulers too,” said I. “Do not presume that what I have said applies any more to men than it does to those women among their number who are naturally equipped for the role.” “You are right,” said he, “if they really are to share everything equally with the men, as we have explained.”

^{540d}

“Well, then,” said I, “do you agree that what we have said about the city and its system of government has not been a mere aspiration? Rather, although it is difficult, it is still possible, but only in the way we have described. Whenever true philosophers, many or just one, come to power in the city, despise the honours of the age, which they regard as unworthy of free men and attach most importance to what is right and to the honours that come from that, and treat justice as ^{540e} supreme and absolutely necessary, then by serving this and strengthening this they will set their own city in order.” “How?” said he.

^{541a}

“They will send anyone in the city who happens to be more than ten years old,” said I, “out into the countryside. They will then isolate the children from their present habits, the habits of their parents, and bring them up in their own manners and regulations, the sort we just described. And once the city and form of government we were speaking of has been established very quickly and easily in this way, do you not agree that it will be a happy city and that the people among whom it arises will benefit enormously?” “Very much so,” he said. “And I think, Socrates, that you have described nicely how it might come into existence, if it were ever to do so.”

^{541b}

“At this stage,” said I, “have we not had our fill of arguments about this city and the sort of person who resembles it? For surely it is also obvious what sort of person we shall say he must be.” “It is obvious,” said he. “And as for your question, I think that is the end of the matter.”

BOOK VIII

543a

“So, there it is. This has now been agreed, Glaucon. For a city to be governed at its very best, women are to be shared, children are to be shared, and all education too. And in like manner, all activities are to be shared, both in war and in peace, and those among them who turn out best in philosophy, and in warfare too, are to be their kings.” “This was agreed,” said he.

543b

“And indeed, we also accepted that once the rulers are in place, they will take the soldiers in hand and settle them in living arrangements of the sort we have already described, which are common to all, with nothing private to anyone. And as well as such living arrangements, we also agreed upon the sort of possessions they will have, as you may recall.”

543c

“Yes,” said he, “I recall. We thought that none of them should acquire any of the possessions that everyone else has nowadays. Rather, like warrior athletes and guardians, they must care for themselves and for the rest of the city, accepting their guardians’ pay for the year from the others, to sustain them in their work.” “You are right,” said I, “but come on. Now that we have concluded this, let us remember where we digressed from so that we may proceed along the same course once more.”

543d

“That is not difficult,” said he. “You presented your arguments about the city then, much as you are doing now, as though the

exposition was complete. You proposed a city, saying that a city like the one you had described was good, and so was the man who resembled it, ^{544a} even though, it seems, you were able to speak of a still more beautiful city and a more beautiful man too. But in any case, you were saying that if this city is right, the others are in error, and you maintained, as I recall, that there are four other forms of government besides this one. You said these would be worth describing to see their particular errors and the kinds of people who resemble these forms, and having agreed upon who is the most excellent and who is the worst man, we might then investigate whether the most excellent person is happiest, and the worst is most wretched, or whether the situation is otherwise. And when ^{544b} I was asking you which four forms of government you meant, Polemarchus and Adimantus interrupted at that stage, and so it was that you took up the argument again and arrived here.” “That is right,” said I. “You have remembered this very well.” “So then, like a wrestler, offer me the same hold once more, and in response to my same question try to say what you were about to say at the time.” “I shall, if I am able to,” said I. “And, indeed,” said he, “I am also anxious to learn for myself what four forms of government you were referring to then.”

^{544c}

“That is not difficult,” said I, “so listen. The forms I am referring to are those that have names. First is the one that most people praise, your Cretan or Spartan form. Second to arise, and second ^{544d} too in terms of praise, is the one called oligarchy, a form of government full of evils aplenty. Next comes the adversary of this form, democracy. And then there is noble tyranny, set apart from all the others, the fourth and last disease of the city. Or can you think of any other form of government of any type that constitutes another obvious form? Indeed dynasties, purchased kingships, and other forms of government of this sort are presumably something intermediate between these four, and

they are to be found no less among non-Greeks than among the Greeks.” “Yes,” said he, “many unusual forms are spoken of.”

544e

“Now,” said I, “do you know that there must be as many types of human character as there are forms of government? Or do you think that forms of government come into existence from oak or from rock,¹⁰³ and not from the characters of the people in the cities, which, in a sense, exert their influence and pull everything else in their direction.” “Yes,” said he, “that is where they come from and not from anywhere else at all.” “In that case, if there are five types of cities, there would also be five conditions of individual souls.” “Indeed.” “Well now, we have already described the person who resembles the aristocracy, whom we rightly declare to be good and just.” “We have.”

545a

“Now, after this should we not describe the lesser men: first, the ambitious fellow who loves honour, and corresponds to the Spartan form of government, then the oligarchic man, the democratic and, finally, the tyrannical? Would this not enable us to look at the most unjust man alongside the most just man, and complete our enquiry as to where exactly pure justice stands relative to pure injustice, in relation to the happiness or wretchedness of their possessor, so that we could either be persuaded by Thrasymachus and pursue injustice, or accept the argument that is now emerging, and pursue justice?” “Yes,” said he, “that is what we should do. Entirely so.”

545b

“Well now, we began this process by considering the characters of the various forms of government – where they are more obvious – prior to considering those of the individuals. So, should we proceed in a similar way now, and consider first the form of government that loves honour? In our language I have no other name to call it except timocracy or timarchy, and in relation to this we shall consider the man who resembles it.

Then, after that, we shall consider the oligarchy and the oligarchic man. And after looking at the democracy, we shall behold the democratic man. And arriving at the fourth city, the tyrannical one, and looking at that, and at the tyrannical soul too, we shall try to become competent judges of the issues we have put forward.”

545c

“Well,” said he, “if we proceed in this way, our perspective and our judgement would surely be reasonable.” “Come on, then,” said I. “Let us try to describe the way in which timocracy would arise from aristocracy. Or is it simply that change in any form of government comes from the part of it that exercises authority, whenever faction arises in that particular part, whereas if it is of one mind, even if it is very small, no disturbance is possible?” “Yes, indeed so.”

545d

“So, Glaucon,” said I, “how shall this city of ours be disturbed, and in what way shall our auxiliaries and our rulers develop factions against one another, and against themselves? Or would you prefer that we copy Homer and pray to the Muses to tell us how faction first came about,¹⁰⁴ and we could declare that they are playing with us, like children, speaking lightly but in a tragic style, pretending to be serious by speaking in a lofty manner?”

545e

“How?”

546a

“As follows. Although it is difficult to disturb a city that has been constituted in this way, nevertheless, since destruction is the lot of anything that has come into being, even something constituted like this will not endure for all time. It too will be dissolved, and its dissolution will be as follows. Not alone for the plants in the earth, but also among the animals on the earth there is productiveness and sterility of their souls and bodies as they run their circular course and complete their cycles, ^{546b}

which are short for those who are short-lived, and longer for the long-lived. But for your race, although the people whom you educated as leaders of the city are wise, they will be unable by calculation combined with sense experience, to hit upon the best time for bringing children to birth and for not bearing children. This will evade them, and they will, on occasion, bring forth children when they should not.

546c

“Now, divine birth has a cycle that the perfect number encompasses. But for a human being the number is the first in which root and square increases, having comprehended three distances and four limits of whatever brings about likenesses and unlikenesses, waxings and wanings, renders all things mutually agreeable and expressible towards one another. Of these four, three yoked together with five yields two harmonies when increased threefold. The first is equal, an equal number of times, one hundred times this amount. The other is equal in length on one side, but it is oblong on the other side of one hundred squares of rational diameters of five diminished by one each, or, if of irrational diameters, by two, on the other side of one hundred cubes of three.

546d

“This entire geometrical number is lord of anything like this,¹⁰⁵ of better and worse births. And whenever our guardians, in ignorance of this, make brides cohabit with bridegrooms inappropriately, their children will be neither well developed nor fortunate. And although their predecessors will install the best of them in power, nevertheless, being unworthy, when their turn comes to rule and exercise the powers of their fathers, they will begin, as guardians, firstly to pay little heed to us Muses by regarding our realm of music as less important, and secondly they will neglect ^{546e} the realm of gymnastics too, and so your own young people will become less musical. From these, ^{547a} rulers will be installed who cannot exercise much

guardianship when it comes to testing for the races of Hesiod,¹⁰⁶ and of your people too, the gold, silver, bronze and iron. The indiscriminate mixing of iron with silver and of bronze with gold will produce dissimilarity and an inappropriate inconsistency, which always beget war and enmity wherever they arise. So, we should declare that ‘such is the lineage’ of faction,¹⁰⁷ whenever and wherever it occurs.” “And we shall declare,” said he, “that they have answered correctly.” “As they must,” said I, “since they are Muses.”

547b

“Well, then,” said he, “what shall the Muses say next?” “Once faction had arisen,” said I, “both races began to exert their influence, the iron and brass kinds drawing the city towards the acquisition of money, land and property, gold and silver, while the gold and silver kinds, for their part – since these are not in poverty but are naturally wealthy of soul – led in the direction of excellence and the ancient order. As they struggled violently in opposite directions, they eventually agreed to compromise, distribute land and property for themselves, and make these private. With this, they enslaved those they had previously guarded as free men, friends and supporters by treating them as serfs and underlings, while they themselves 547c attended to warfare and guarding themselves against their former friends.” “I think,” said he, “that this is how the change comes about.” “Would not this form of government,” said I, “be something in between aristocracy and oligarchy?” “Very much so.”

547d

“Well, that is how it will change, but once it has changed, how will it be administered? Or is it obvious that in some respects it will imitate the previous form of government, and in other respects 547e the oligarchy, since it is in between them, and that it will also have something that is particular to itself?” “Quite so,” said he. “In the respect given to its rulers, the fact that its military class refrains from working the land and from skilled

labour and from other sorts of money-making, in its provision of common meals and the attention it pays to physical exercise and military competition, in everything of this sort will it not imitate the previous form?" "Yes."

548a

"Will not the features that, for the most part, are particular to itself be its fear of admitting the wise to positions of authority since it no longer has people of this sort who are straightforward and sincere, rather than complicated? Will it not also prefer spirited types who are simpler, more fitted by nature for war than peace, who attach value to its tactics and strategies? And will it not spend all its time waging war?" "Yes."

548b

"And yet," said I, "people like this will have a longing for money, just like those in the oligarchies, harbouring a concealed but fierce reverence for gold and silver because they have storehouses and private treasuries in which to keep it all hidden, and enclosures too, houses which are really private nests in which they spend their money, lavishing it extravagantly on women and on many others, whomever they please." "Very true," said he.

548c

"And they will also be miserly with money since they revere it and may not acquire it openly. Yet because of desire, they love spending other people's money and enjoying their pleasures in secret, running away from the law like boys from their father, having been educated by force rather than persuasion because they paid no heed to the true Muse who accompanies argument and philosophy, and had more respect for gymnastics than for music." "You are," said he, "most certainly describing a form of government that is a mixture of good and bad."

548d

"Yes, it is mixed," said I, "but what is most distinctive about it is one particular feature. Due to the dominance of spiritedness in

it, it is ambitious and loves honour.” “Most certainly,” said he. “Well,” said I, “this form of government would arise in this way, and this is what it would be like. This is just a verbal sketch providing an outline without the detail, because a sketch will indeed be enough to reveal the most just person, and the most unjust. But to describe all forms of government and all their characters, omitting nothing, would be an inordinately lengthy undertaking.” “That is right,” said he.

548e

“Now, what about the man who corresponds to this form of government? How did he arise, and what sort of person is he?” “I think,” said Adimantus, “that when it comes to ambition, at any rate, he is quite like Glaucon here.” “Well, in that respect,” said I, “perhaps you are right, but in other respects his nature is different.” “In what respects?”

549a

“He must be more stubborn,” said I, “and less musical, even though he loves music, and despite being a good listener he is not at all eloquent. And he would be aggressive towards slaves rather than merely looking down upon them, as an adequately educated person would do. Yet he would ^{549b} be gentle towards free men, and highly respectful towards those in authority. He himself loves authority and he loves honour, and he is worthy of authority, not because of what he says or anything of that sort, but because of his achievements on the battlefield and in military affairs generally, being fond of physical exercise and of hunting.” “Yes,” said he, “this is the character of that form of government.” “Would not a person like this,” said I, “despise money when young, but grow more and more fond of it the older he gets because he has a share of this money-loving nature and is no longer directed towards excellence, purely and simply, because he has been deprived of its very best guardian?” “What is that?” asked Adimantus. “Reason,” said I, “combined with music, which alone, once engendered, dwells as the

lifelong preserver of excellence for whoever possesses it.” “Very good,” said he. “So, that is what the young timocrat is like,” said I. “He is just like this sort of city.” “Yes, indeed.”

549c

“Now, this person arises somewhat as follows,” said I. “Sometimes he is the young son of a good father who is living in a city that is not well run. His father shuns the honours, the positions of authority, legal disputes and all business of that sort, and he is willing to accept loss of status to avoid trouble.” “And how,” he asked, “does he become timocratic?”

549d

“Whenever,” said I, “in the first place, he hears his mother being annoyed at the fact that her husband is not one of the rulers, and that she is losing status among the other women as a result. She sees that he is not particularly serious about money and does not fight or engage in slander, either in private or in the law courts or public gatherings, but is indifferent to everything like this. She notices that he is constantly turned in on himself, does not show her much respect, and does not disrespect her either. And she gets annoyed at all this and tells her son that his father is unmanly and extremely neglectful, and she repeats all the other expressions of this sort that women like to use when speaking of such men.”

549e

“Yes,” said Adimantus, “there are lots of them. That is what they are like.” “And you know,” said I, “that the servants of such men, the ones that seem well-intentioned, sometimes say this sort of thing secretly to the sons. And if they see someone owing money to his father, or someone doing him some other injustice, someone whom the father will not pursue, they exhort ^{550a} him to take revenge on all such people when he becomes a man, and be more of a man than his father. And when he goes out he hears and sees other things of this sort. Those who do what belongs to themselves in the city are called

simple-minded and are held in little regard, while those who do not are honoured and praised. Then the young man, seeing and hearing all this, and also hearing the words of his father and seeing his father's actions from close up, alongside those of everyone ^{550b} else, is dragged in both directions: his father encouraging and fostering the rational element in his soul, while the others foster the appetitive and spirited elements. Because he is not, by nature, a bad man, but has fallen into bad company of others, he is pulled by both of these, ends up in the middle, hands over the authority within himself to the middle element of ambition and spiritedness, and becomes a high-spirited man who loves honour." "I think," said he, "that you have described the origin of this fellow quite accurately."

^{550c}

"In that case," said I, "we have our second form of government, and the corresponding man too." "We have, indeed," said he. "After this, should we, as Aeschylus says, speak of 'another man set before another city'¹⁰⁸ or, according to our procedure, speak of the city first?" "Yes, certainly," said he. "And the form of government that comes after this one would, I think, be oligarchy." "Well," said he, "what kind of constitution do you call oligarchy?" "The one that is based on a property qualification," said I, "in which the rich rule and the poor man has no share of authority." "I understand," said he.

^{550d}

"Should we not say how the change from timocracy to oligarchy first begins?" "Yes." "And, indeed," said I, "even to the blind, it is obvious how this changes." "How?" "That treasury," said I, "private to each, filled with gold, is what destroys a form of government of this sort. For in the first place they invent various extravagances for themselves, and divert the laws to this end by disobeying them themselves, and their wives do likewise." "Quite likely," said he. "Next, I imagine, they start watching each other, and by entering into rivalry they

eventually make almost everyone else behave just like themselves.” “That is likely.”

550e

“And, thereafter,” said I, “as they proceed further with their money-making, the more honour they assign to wealth, the less honour they assign to excellence. Or is this not how excellence contrasts with wealth, as if they were each being weighed on a balance that is constantly inclining in opposite directions?” “Very much so,” said he. “So, when wealth and the wealthy people are honoured in a city, excellence and the good people are shown less honour.” “Evidently.” “But whatever is honoured constantly is practised, and whatever is dishonoured is neglected.” “Just so.”

551a

“Then, instead of being ambitious men who love honour, they finally become men who love money and money-making. They praise the wealthy man, and they are in awe of him and put him in positions of authority, while they dishonour the poor man.” “Absolutely.” “And at that stage they pass a law that defines the oligarchical form of government. They prescribe a particular sum of money, which is more when it is more of an oligarchy, less when it is less so, and they decree that anyone whose property falls short of the prescribed valuation may have no involvement in ruling the city. They bring this about either through force of arms, or else they will establish a form of government like this through fear. Is this not so?” “Yes, this is so.”

551b

“Well then, this is what we might call its establishment.” “Yes,” said he. “But what is the manner of this form of government, and what defects do we say it possesses?” “Well, firstly,” said I, “consider its own defining characteristic and what it is like. What if helmsmen for ships were to be appointed based upon a property qualification, and the poor man was never given the

role, even if he was a better helmsman?" "Their sea voyage," said he, "would be terrible." "Does not the same also apply to the control of anything else at all?" "Yes, I think so." "Except a city," said I. "Or does this also apply to a city?"

551c

"Very much so," said he, "to a city most of all, since the rule of a city is so difficult and important."

551d

"Then oligarchy would possess this one significant defect." "Apparently." "What about this? Is the following defect any less significant?" "Which one?" "The fact that such a city is not one, but necessarily two: a city of poor folk and a city of wealthy people, living in the same place but always scheming against one another." "By Zeus," said he, "that is not a less significant defect!"

551e

"And, indeed, it is not good that they are unlikely to be able to wage a war, because that compels them either to arm the general population, and then be more afraid of them than of the enemy, or not to arm them and thus be true oligarchs, a few rulers alone on the battlefield. And at the same time they are unwilling to contribute to military expenditure because they love money so much." "Not good, indeed." "And what about the aspect we criticised a while ago? What about the fact that people have lots of different roles? Under such a form of government, the same people simultaneously engage in ^{552a} agriculture, make money, and fight in wars. Do you think this is all right?" "No, not at all." "Then let us see if such a form of government is the first to tolerate the greatest of all these evils." "Which is?" "Allowing someone to sell everything he has, and allowing someone else to take possession of this. Having sold everything, the man may live on in the city without any role as a businessman, ^{552b} a craftsman, a cavalryman or an infantry-man. They call him poor, a man without means." "It is

the first to tolerate this,” said he. “This sort of thing certainly will not be prohibited in oligarchies or else some people could not be excessively wealthy while others are in total poverty.” “That is right.” “Think about this too. When he was still wealthy, was this fellow of any more benefit to the city in the various roles we have described? Or did he seem to be one of the rulers of the city, when in truth he was neither a ruler nor an underling, but a mere spender of anything that was available?”

552c

“That is it,” said he. “He seemed to be something else, but he was nothing more than a spendthrift.” “Would you like us to declare,” said I, “that just as a drone is born in a cell of honeycomb, a pestilence to the hive, so too is a man like this, born in a private dwelling house, a drone and a pestilence to the city?” “Yes, certainly, Socrates,” said he. “Now, Adimantus, although the god made all the winged drones without any stings, did he not make some of the drones that go by foot stingless, and others with terrible stings? Is it not the case 552d that those who remain beggars to the very end belong to the stingless sort, while all the so-called evildoers are from the drones which have stings?” “Very true,” said he. “So, it is evident”, said I, “that in any city where you see beggars, there are thieves and cutpurses somewhere in the vicinity, hidden away, temple robbers too, and artificers of all sorts of evil deeds.” “That is evident,” said he. “What about this? Do you not see beggars in the oligarchical cities?” “Yes,” said he, “almost everyone apart from those in authority are beggars.”

552e

“Should we not presume, then,” said I, “that there are also lots of evildoers in these cities, complete with stings, whom the rulers deliberately restrain by force?” “We should presume so,” said he. “Well then, shall we declare that people like this arise there because of ill-education, bad upbringing, and the evil foundations of this form of government?” “We shall.” “In that

case then, the oligarchical city would be something of this sort, and would have as many evils as this, and perhaps even more.” “That just about sums it up,” said he.

553a

“Then,” said I, “we have dealt with this form of government too, the one they call oligarchy, the one having rulers appointed on the basis of a property qualification. Next, we should consider the person who resembles this, how he arises, and what he is like once he has arisen.” “Yes, certainly,” said he. “Does not the change from that timocratic type to the oligarchic type take place, for the most part, as follows?” “How?”

553b

“It happens when a son, born to a timocratic man, emulates his father at first and follows in that man’s footsteps. Then he sees him suddenly dashed against the city, like a ship against a reef, his property and the man himself being lost overboard. Perhaps he was serving as a general, or exercising some other important position of authority, and then ended up in court because of damaging allegations by false informers, and was put to death, or exiled, or lost his civil rights and had all his property confiscated.” “Quite likely,” said he.

553c

“And the son, my friend, seeing all this, suffering its consequences and losing all his property, is presumably afraid, and immediately thrusts any love of honour, and that spiritedness too, from the throne in his own soul. Humbled by poverty, he turns to money-making, and greedily, gradually, by being thrifty and working hard, he gets some money together. Now, do you not think someone like this, at that stage, would install the appetitive element with its love of money on that throne, turn this into the Great King within himself, and deck it out with tiaras, necklets and ceremonial swords?” “I do,” said he.

553d

“And I presume that he seats the rational and the spirited elements on the ground on either side, beneath that king, as his slaves. He would not allow the rational element to work out or consider anything except how to turn smaller sums of money into larger ones. And he would not allow the spirited element to hold anything in awe, or to have any respect for anything apart from wealth and wealthy people, or to take pride in anything at all except the acquisition of wealth, and anything that brings this about.” “There is,” said he, “no other transformation of a young man who loves honour into one who loves money that is as swift and sure as this.”

553e

“So, is this fellow our oligarchical man?” I asked. “Well, at any rate, the transformation of this fellow starts with a man who resembles the timocracy, the form that turns into oligarchy.” “Let us investigate whether he himself resembles the oligarchy.” “Let us investigate it.” “Would he not resemble it firstly by assigning the utmost importance to money?” “Of course.” “And, indeed, by being miserly and diligent, satisfying only the most necessary of his desires without making provision for any other expenditure and enslaving the other desires because they are unprofitable.” “Yes, certainly.”

554a

“He is a squalid fellow,” said I, “a man who builds up a fortune by making a profit out of everything, the sort of man that most people praise. Would not this person be the one who resembles a form of government like oligarchy?”

554b

“Well, I think so,” said he. “At any rate, money is what this city honours most, and so does a man like this.” “Yes,” said I, “presumably because a man like this has not paid attention to education.” “It seems not,” said he, “or else he would not have installed blind wealth as the leader of his chorus, and honoured this most.”¹⁰⁹ “Nicely explained,” said I, “but consider this.

Should we not state that because of his lack of education, drone-like desires arise in him – the desires of the beggar in some cases, those of the evildoer in others – but these are restrained by his other concern?”

554c

“Indeed,” said he, “very much so.” “Now,” said I, “do you know where you will see the evil deeds of these people, if you look?” “Where?” he asked. “In their guardianship of orphans, and any other opportunity like this that arises, where they get unrestricted licence to act unjustly.” “True.” “So is it not obvious from this that in the other business dealings, those in which a man like this is well regarded and seems to be acting justly, he is forcibly restraining other bad innate desires ^{554d} by some moderation of his own devising? He does not persuade them that it is better not to do this, nor does he tame them by reason, but by compulsion and fear, because he is afraid of losing the rest of his property.” “Yes, entirely so,” said he. “And, by Zeus, my friend,” said I, “once they have the opportunity to spend other people’s money, you will find that the drone-like desires are present in most of them.” “Yes,” said he, “with great intensity.”

554e

“So a man like this would not be free of internal factions, nor would he be one person, but somehow double, although his better desires would, for the most part, prevail over his worse desires.” “Quite so.” “Because of this, I believe, such a person would be more respectable than many others. But the true excellence of the even-minded and harmonious soul would escape him by some distance.” “I think so.”

555a

“And, indeed, this miserly fellow, as a private citizen, is a poor competitor when it comes to any civic ambition or love of noble achievements as he is not prepared to spend money for the sake of good reputation, or on any rivalries of this sort. He is afraid

to awaken the desires that make him spend money and summon them to join the battle and fulfil his ambition. So he fights like a true oligarch with only a few of his own resources, loses most of the time, but remains wealthy.” “Very much so,” said he.

555b

“Now,” said I, “are we still in any doubt that the miserly money-maker corresponds to the oligarchical city, and resembles it?” “Not at all,” said he. “Then we should, it seems, consider the democracy next, the manner in which it arises and what it is like once it has arisen. This will allow us to recognise the character of the man who is like this, and judge him alongside the others.” “Well, we would at least be proceeding much as we did earlier,” said he. “Does not the change from oligarchy to democracy come about, somehow, because of this insatiable desire for what is presented as good, this need to become as wealthy as possible?” I asked. “How so?”

555c

“Since the rulers hold office in that city because they have acquired so much wealth, they are, I think, unwilling to restrict by law any young people who are becoming unrestrained, and prevent them from spending and wasting all they possess. This enables them to buy up the property of such young folk, and also to lend money on security of the property, thus becoming even wealthier and more privileged than before.” “More than anything.”

555d

“Now, is it not obvious already that in a city it is impossible to have reverence for wealth and sufficient sound-mindedness among the citizens at the same time? Is it not necessary rather to neglect one or the other?” “Yes,” said he, “that is fairly obvious.” “In fact, when they neglect this in the oligarchies, and encourage unrestrained behaviours, good people are sometimes forced into poverty.” “Very much so.” “So these people, I imagine, sit there in the city, complete with stings in armed

array, some of them in debt, some of them deprived of their rights, some in both predicaments. They hate and conspire against those who took their possessions, and against everyone else too, and they are passionate for revolution.” “That is right.”

555e

“And yet, the money-makers, keeping their heads down and without even seeming to notice these people, insert their silver, injuring anyone else who does not consistently resist them. And they recover their original sum many times over in interest, and cause the drone and the beggar to multiply in the city.” “Yes,” said he, “why would they not multiply?”

556a

“Nor,” said I, “are they willing to extinguish an evil of this sort, as it blazes up in the city, by restricting a person’s right to do what he likes with his own property, nor again will they undo such arrangements by another law.” “What law do you mean?” “A law that is second best after that, one that compels the citizens to pay attention to excellence. For if it were decreed that a person enters into most voluntary contracts at his own risk, there would be less shameless money-making in the city and fewer evils like those we have been describing would spring up there.” “Much fewer,” said he.

556b

“But as matters stand,” said I, “for all sorts of reasons, such as those we have given, the rulers of the city put their subjects in this predicament. As for themselves and their own kindred, do they not make the young folk delicate, averse to hard work, be it physical or mental, too soft to withstand pleasures or pains, and lazy too?” “Indeed.” “And do they not turn themselves into money-makers who neglect everything else besides this, caring no more for excellence than the poor people do?” “Yes, no more than that.”

556c

“Then, under such an arrangement, whenever the rulers and their subjects come into contact with one another, either on a journey or in some other communal activities such as a festival, or on a military campaign as shipmates or fellow soldiers, and when they see one another facing actual dangers, the poor are no longer held in contempt by the wealthy folk at all. Indeed, very often the poor man, lean and sunburnt, stationed in battle beside a wealthy man who has been reared in the shade, with far more flesh than he needs, sees this rich fellow out of breath and in total confusion.

556d

So, do you not think he will then conclude that such people are wealthy due to some failing on the part of the poor, and when the poor get together in private will they not proclaim to one another that ‘These men are good for nothing. They are ours for the taking.’?” “I know quite well,” said he, “that that is what they will do.”

556e

“Is it not like an unhealthy body that needs only the slightest external influence to tip it into disease, and is sometimes in conflict with itself, without any external influence? Will not a city that is in the same condition as that unhealthy body become diseased at the slightest prompting, and fight against itself? Perhaps one group might bring in allies from an oligarchic state, or the others might bring them in from a democratic state, and there may sometimes be conflict even without any external influence.”

557a

“Yes, emphatically so.” “Then democracy, I imagine, comes about when the poor, having won their victory, execute some of their opponents, exile others, and grant an equal involvement in civic affairs and in positions of authority to those who remain. And positions of authority in the city are, for the most part, assigned by lot.” “This is indeed how the democracy is

established,” said he, “whether it happens through force of arms, or the others withdraw out of fear.”

557b

“Well, then,” said I, “in what way do these people live their lives, and what will a form of government of this sort be like? For it is obvious that a man like this will prove to be a democratic man.” “That is obvious,” said he. “Well, in the first place, are they not free, and does not the city become full of freedom and unrestricted speech, with licence for anyone there to do what he likes?” “So they say, anyway,” said he. “And wherever there is licence, it is obvious that each person would make individual arrangements for his own life there, an arrangement that pleases him.” “That is obvious.”

557c

“So under this form of government especially, I imagine, an enormous variety of people of all sorts would arise.” “Inevitably.” “Perhaps,” said I, “it is the most beautiful of all the forms of government. Just like a many coloured robe, embroidered with flowers of all sorts, this city, decked out with characters of all sorts, would prove to be the most beautiful one there is. Indeed, it is quite likely that most people, just like children and women when they see decorated objects, would decide that this form of government is the most beautiful one.” “Very much so,” said he. “And, indeed, my friend,” said I, “it is somehow quite appropriate to search for a form of government in this one.”

557d

“Why is that?” “Because it contains forms of government of every kind on account of the licence that it allows. Indeed, anyone who intends to arrange a city, as we have been doing just now, should really go to one that is governed democratically and select whatever arrangement pleases him, as if he was entering a general market selling forms of government of all sorts, to make his selection and found his city

accordingly.” “Well,” said he, “there would surely be no shortage of examples to choose from.”

557e

“There is no compulsion to exercise authority in this city, even if you are qualified to do so,” said I, “or indeed to be subject to authority if you do not feel like it, or to go to war in time of war, or to observe the peace when everyone else does so, if you do not want peace. What is more, if some law is preventing you from holding office or being on a jury, you may hold office or serve on the ^{558a} jury anyway, if it suits you to do so. Now, is this not a divinely pleasant and sweet way of carrying on, for a while?” “For a while, perhaps,” said he. “And what about the calmness of those who have ended up in court? Is that not nice? Or have you never seen people who have been sentenced to death or exile under a form of government like this, remaining on in the city nevertheless, and going about in public. Or how a convicted person stalks about the place unheeded and unseen by anyone, like a ghost?” “This happens a lot,” said he.

558b

“And note the tolerance of this form of government and its lack of any attention to detail. It despises anything we were so serious about when we were founding our city, and said that unless someone had an exceptional nature, he would never become a good man unless he were to play in the midst of beauty from his earliest childhood and engage in pursuits of a similar sort thereafter. See how high-mindedly it tramples upon all this, pays no heed to the sort of pursuits someone engaged in before they got involved in public life, but honours him as long as he declares that he is well disposed towards the people.” “How utterly noble,” said he.

558c

“So democracy would, it seems, have these qualities and others akin to these,” said I. “It is a pleasant form of government, anarchic and variegated, that bestows some equality on equals

and unequals alike.” “Yes,” said he, “what you say is all very recognisable.” “Then,” said I, “think carefully about what the corresponding person will be like. Or should we first consider how he arises, just as we did with the form of government?” “Yes,” said he. “Well, would it not happen in the following way? The miserly oligarchic man might have a son, I imagine, who has been brought up in the habits of his father.” “Yes, why not?”

558d

“Then the son too would forcibly control any pleasures within him that are conducive to spending money rather than making it, the pleasures that are referred to as unnecessary.” “Obviously,” said he. “Now,” said I, “so that we do not discuss this in an obscure manner, do you first want to distinguish between the desires that are necessary and those that are not?” “I do,” said he. “Well, desires which we would be unable to divert, and those whose fulfilment benefits us, may we justifiably refer to these as necessary? In fact, it is necessary for us, by our very nature, to pursue both of these. Is this not so?” “Very much so.”

558e

“Then we may justifiably use the word ‘necessary’ to refer to these.” “Justifiably.” “What about those which someone may be rid of, through practice from his earliest years, which do not do him any good when they are present, and can indeed do the opposite? If we declare that all these are unnecessary, would we be right to say so?” “Right, indeed.” “Then should we pick an example of each, so that we may grasp what they are, in rough outline?” “We should do that.”

559a

“Would not the desire to eat just to maintain health and well-being, the desire just for bread and for relish, be necessary?” “I believe so.” “The desire for bread is presumably necessary for both reasons; it is beneficial, and it can bring

our lives to an end if we do not satisfy it.” “Yes.” “Whereas the desire for relish is necessary insofar as it confers some benefit in terms of well-being.” “Yes, certainly.” “What about desire that goes beyond these, desire for different things to eat besides this sort of food, desire that is capable of being eliminated from most people by restraint and education from their earlier years and is harmful to the body and harmful to the soul’s intelligence and soundness ^{559c} of mind? May this correctly be referred to as not necessary?” “Most correctly.” “Now, should we not say that these desires are conducive to spending money, and the others to making money because they are useful in relation to work?” “Indeed.” “And shall we say the same about sexual desires and the others?” “The same.” “Now, is it not the case that the fellow we called a drone just now, this man, according to us, is full of pleasures and desires of this sort, and is ruled by the unnecessary ones, while the miserly oligarchic type is ruled by the necessary ones?” “Yes, indeed.”

^{559d}

“Well,” said I, “let us go back again and say how the democratic type arises from the oligarchic. It seems to me to happen, in general, as follows.” “How?” “Whenever a young man, brought up in the manner we just described – ill-educated and miserly, being a mere drone – gets a taste of honey and keeps company with wild, clever creatures who are ^{559e} able to ply him with a whole variety of pleasures of all sorts and types, this, you may safely assume, is the source of the change from the oligarchic system within himself to the democratic one.” “It must be,” said he, “very much so.” “Well then, just as the city changed when an external alliance came to the aid of one of its parts, like supporting like, so too does not the young man change when some form of external desire comes in turn to the aid of similar, corresponding, kindred desires within himself?” “Entirely so.”

^{560a}

“And I presume that if some alliance provides assistance, in turn, to the oligarchic element within him, either from his father’s circle or any other relations who are censuring and criticising him, then faction and counter faction and internal warfare against himself arises.” “Indeed.” “And sometimes, I imagine, the democratic element yields to the oligarchic, and some of the desires are destroyed while others are expelled, some shame arises in the soul of the young man, and its good order is restored once again.” “Yes, this sometimes happens,” said he.

560b

“At other times, I believe other desires, akin to those that have been expelled, arise in their place because the father lacks knowledge of proper nurture, and these can become numerous and strong.” “Yes,” said he. “That is what is inclined to happen.” “Do they not drag him back into the same bad company, and by getting together in secret, give birth to a rabble?” “Indeed.” “Then finally, I believe, they seize the citadel of the young man’s soul, having noticed that it is devoid of understanding, noble pursuits and words of truth, which are of course the very best watchmen and guardians in the minds of men whom the gods love.”

560c

“Much the best,” said he. “False and arrogant arguments and opinions then rush up and seize the self-same citadel of a man like this, usurping the place of the true ones.” “With great energy,” said he.

560d

“So, does he not go back once more to those Lotus Eaters and live openly among them this time? And if any assistance from the relatives arrives to help the miserly aspect of his soul, do not those arrogant words close the gates in the walls of the kingly element within him, refuse to allow the alliance itself to get through or to accept the words of private persons who are

older and wiser as ambassadors? They themselves do battle and prevail. Shame they rename as silliness, and they thrust it out as an exile, showing it no respect. Sound-mindedness they rename as unmanliness, and having trampled it in the mud, they cast this out too. Is it not the case that they convince him that measure and orderly expenditure are crude restraints on freedom, and with the help of lots of useless desires, they drive these beyond the frontier?" "They do, indeed."

560e

"And once they have somehow emptied and purged the soul they have occupied and are initiating with magnificent rites, they proceed at that stage to reinstate insolence, anarchy, wastefulness and shamelessness, in a blaze of light, accompanied by a vast procession, crowning them with garlands, singing their praises and calling them by sweet names. They refer to insolence as good education, anarchy as freedom, wastefulness as magnificence, and shamelessness as courage. Is this not somehow the way," said I, "that he changes, as a young man, from being reared on the necessary desires to the liberation and licence that goes with unnecessary and unprofitable pleasures?" "Yes," said he, "that's very clear."

561a

"After all this, I imagine, a person like this lives on, spending money, effort and time on the necessary and unnecessary pleasures in equal measure. But if he is fortunate, and his frenzy does not go beyond all bounds, and he gets a bit older too, then once the great inner tumult has passed he may readmit some parts that he had expelled and not give himself over entirely to the new arrivals. He proceeds to place the various pleasures on some sort of equal footing, handing authority over himself to any pleasure that comes along, in a sort of lottery, until it is satisfied, then he moves on to another, cherishing them all equally and showing no disrespect to any of them." "Yes, certainly."

561b

“And he does not accept true argument,” said I, “nor admit it into that citadel, when someone says that there are pleasures that belong to noble and good desires, and others that belong to base desires, and that the former should be pursued and honoured, while the others are to be restrained and kept in subjection. No, he shakes his head at all such arguments and declares that these pleasures are all much the same, and equally worthy of honour.” “Yes, indeed,” said he, “that is his position and that is what he would do.”

561c

“And that is how he passes his life from day to day,” said I, “gratifying whatever desire comes along. At one moment he is a drunkard, charmed by sweet music; next he becomes a water-drinker and goes on a diet; then he starts exercising, but he soon gets lazy and completely careless, and after that he seems to be engaged in philosophy. He often turns to politics, jumping up and saying ^{561d} or doing whatever occurs to him, and if he ever develops an admiration for military folk, he takes himself off in that direction, or he might admire business people and go that way instead. There is no order in his life, nor any compulsion to do anything, and yet he calls this life pleasant, free and blessed, and he holds to this through and through.” “You have,” said he, “given a comprehensive description of a ‘legal equality man’.”

561e

“And I think,” said I, “that he is a man of great variety, full of character traits aplenty, and this fellow, just like that city, is the fair and many-coloured one. Most men and women would admire his life, which contains so many models for systems of government and personal traits.” “Yes,” he said, “that is him.”

562a

“Well now, should we have aligned a person like this with the democracy as a man who may correctly be referred to as

democratic?” “We should,” said he. “Then,” said I, “all that is left for us to describe is the most beautiful form of government and the most beautiful man – tyranny and the tyrant.” “Certainly,” said he. “Come on then, my dear friend, what does the manner of tyranny prove to be? Indeed, it is quite obvious that it develops out of a democracy.” “It is.” “Now, does tyranny arise from democracy in somewhat the same manner as democracy arose from oligarchy?” “In what manner?”

562b

“The good that they proposed,” said I, “which is the very basis of the oligarchy, was wealth. Is this not so?” “Yes.” “Well, the insatiable desire for wealth, and the disregard of everything else in favour of making money, destroyed the oligarchy.” “True,” said he. “And whatever democracy defines as good, and the insatiable desire for this, is what breaks the democracy apart, is it not?” “What, according to you, does it define as good?”

562c

“Freedom,” said I. “For you would surely hear it said in the democratically governed city, that this is its most precious possession, and that’s why it is the only city worth living in for anyone who is free by nature.” “Yes, indeed,” said he. “That is what is said, and it is said often.” “Well, then,” said I, “as I was just about to say, the insatiable desire for this sort of thing, to the neglect of everything else, changes this form of government too, and puts it in a position where it needs tyranny.” “How so?” he asked.

562d

“This happens, I believe, whenever a democratically governed city with a thirst for freedom gets leaders who behave like bad wine pourers. The city gets intoxicated by drinking too much unadulterated freedom, and unless the rulers are very obliging and provide the city with a lot of freedom, it punishes them and accuses them of being despicable oligarchs.” “Yes,” said he,

“that is what it does.” “And,” said I, “it hurls insults at those who are obedient to their rulers for being willing slaves and mere nobodies. But in private, and publicly too, it praises and honours any rulers who are like the subjects, and any subjects who are like rulers. Now, is it not inevitable that freedom in a city like this would extend to everything?”

562e

“How could it do otherwise?” “And this,” said I, “must also seep down into private households, my friend, until finally the anarchy springs up even among the wild beasts.” “How are we saying this happens?” he asked.

563a

“We would say, for example,” said I, “that a father gets accustomed to behaving like a child and is afraid of his sons. A son behaves like a father and feels neither shame nor fear before his parents so that he may, of course, be free. A foreigner residing in the city has equal status with a citizen, and a citizen has equal status with a foreigner, and the same applies to a visitor.” “Indeed,” said he, “that is what happens.”

563b

“It does,” said I, “and there are other trivial examples. A teacher in such a situation fears and flatters the pupils, while the pupils belittle their teachers and whoever else is put in charge of them. And the young become like their elders in all respects, competing with them in word and deed, while the elders come down to the level of the young folk by being full of banter and wit, imitating the young for fear of seeming disagreeable or oppressive.” “Very much so,” said he.

563c

“And yet, my friend,” said I, “freedom in such a city reaches its extreme when slaves, male and female, are just as free as those who buy them. And I almost forgot to mention how much equality and freedom there is among women in relation to men, and among men in relation to women.” “Should we not follow

Aeschylus,” said he, “and say ‘whatever now comes to our lips?’” “Certainly,” said I, “and accordingly I say that unless he had experienced it first hand, no one would believe how much freer the domesticated animals are in this city than in any other. Indeed, it is literally the case that, as the proverb says, ‘the bitches become just like their mistresses’. And, indeed, horses and donkeys get used to going about with total freedom and solemnity, bumping into anyone they happen to meet on the road who doesn’t get out of their way, and everything else becomes just as full of freedom.” “You are describing my own dream,” said he. “I experience this myself when I am making my way out into the countryside.”

563d

“And,” said I, “the outcome of all of these factors combined together is the observable softness it produces in the souls of the citizens. Consequently, if anyone tries to introduce any subjugation to any authority at all, they get angry and cannot stand it. Indeed, I am sure you recognise that in the end they don’t even pay attention to the laws, written or unwritten, so that no one may have any authority whatsoever over them.” “Yes,” said he, “I know quite well.” “Well, my friend,” said I, “this, in my view, is the beautiful and high-spirited source from which a tyranny springs up.” “High-spirited, indeed,” said he. “But what happens after this?”

563e

“The same disease,” said I, “that developed in the oligarchy, and destroyed it, also develops in the democracy, but it is more pervasive and more virulent on account of the licence it allows, and it dominates the democracy completely. In fact, anything that is done to excess tends to reciprocate with an enormous corresponding change in the opposite direction, in seasons, in plants and in human bodies, and especially in forms of government.” “Quite likely,” said he.

564a

“Indeed, the excessive freedom seems to transform simply into excessive slavery in the individual and in the city.” “Yes, quite likely.” “Then,” said I, “it is likely that tyranny arises from no other form of government besides democracy. From the very pinnacle of freedom comes the most extensive and savage slavery.” “Yes,” said he, “that is reasonable.” “But I do not think that is what you were asking,” said I. “I think you asked what kind of disease develops identically in an oligarchy and in a democracy too and reduces it to slavery.” “True,” said he.

564b

“Well,” said I, “I was referring to that class of idle, spendthrift men, the most courageous of whom take the lead while the less vigorous among them follow. These we compare to drones, some having stings, others stingless.” “And rightly so,” said he. “Well,” said I, “these two cause trouble in any city when they arise there. They are like phlegm and bile in the body which a good physician, and a lawgiver in the case of a city must be careful ^{564c} about from afar, just as careful as a wise beekeeper, so that ideally they do not arise in the first place, and then if they do arise they are cut out as quickly as possible, along with the wax that surrounds them.” “Yes, by Zeus,” said he, “entirely so.” “Well,” said I, “to see what we want to see with greater precision, let us proceed in the following way.” “In what way?”

564d

“Let us use the argument to divide the democratically governed city into three, which is how matters actually stand. One part is presumably this drone-like class that develops there, no less than it does in an oligarchy, because there is so much licence.” “So it does.” “But this class is much fiercer in a democracy than in an oligarchy.” “How so?” “In the oligarchy it gets no exercise and doesn’t get strong because it is not respected and it is excluded from positions of authority. But in the democracy, with few exceptions, this is presumably the dominant class, and the fiercest part of it is vocal and active while the rest gather

about the ^{564e} speaker's platform, sit there buzzing, and will not stand for any opposition. Consequently, with few exceptions, everything in such a form of government is managed by this class." "Very much so," said he. "And another distinct part always emerges from the general population as follows." "In what way?" "Presumably, if everyone is involved in making money, those who are by nature most orderly generally become wealthier than everyone else." "Quite likely." "Well, that is where the drones find most honey, and it is easiest to extract from there." "Yes," said he. "How could someone extract it from the others who have so little?" "Then, I imagine, wealthy people like this are called 'the drones' feeding-ground'." "Pretty much," said he.

^{565a}

"The 'People' would be the third class, consisting of easy-going types, those who work their own land and do not own a lot. They constitute the most numerous and most powerful group in a democracy when they gather in an assembly." "That is right," said he, "but they are not inclined to do this very often unless they get a share of the honey." "Do they not always get a share," said I, "as much as the people in charge are able to spare, since they confiscate property from those who have it, distribute some to the people, but hold on to most of it themselves?"

^{565b}

"Yes," said he, "that is indeed how they get a share." "In that case, I imagine, those whose property is being confiscated are compelled to put up a defence by speaking in the assembly and by taking whatever action they can." "Inevitably." "Then an accusation against them is made by those on the other side, and even though they have no desire for revolution, they are accused of conspiring against the people and acting like oligarchs." "Indeed."

^{565c}

“Finally, they see that the people are trying to do them an injustice, not intentionally but out of ignorance, because they have been deceived by various slanderers. And at this stage they really do become oligarchs, whether they wish to do so or not. They are acting against their will, but the drone is stinging them and that is what produces this evil too.” “Yes, exactly.”

565d

“Then the two sides launch impeachments, lawsuits and court cases against one another.” “Very much so.” “And in such a situation are not the people always inclined to put forward one person in particular as their own protector, whom they nurture and turn into a great man?” “That is what they are inclined to do.” “So this much is obvious,” said I. “Whenever a tyrant springs up, the root from which he springs is a protectorate and nothing else.” “Yes, that is quite obvious.”

565e

“So, what is the origin of the change from protector to tyrant? Or is it obvious that this happens once the protector begins to do the same thing as the fellow in the story about the sanctuary of Lycean Zeus in Arcadia?” “What story?” he asked. “The story is that someone who tastes one piece of the innards of a human being, chopped up and mixed with the innards of other sacrificial animals, must necessarily turn into a wolf. Or have you not heard the account?” “I have.”

566a

“Now, does not someone who has become a protector of the people do something like this? Does he not take control of a faithful mob and show no restraint, even to shed the blood of his own people, making unjust accusations, the mob’s usual favourites? And does he not drag someone into court and commit murder, doing away with a man’s life, tasting the blood of his own kin with defiled lips and tongue? Does he not banish people, slay them, and hint at the cancellation of debts and the redistribution of land? Now, is it not inevitable that such a

person, after all this, is destined either to be destroyed by his enemies or to become a tyrant, and transform from a man to a wolf?” “Quite inevitable,” said he.

566b

“Then this fellow,” said I, “turns out to be someone who is at odds with those who own the wealth.” “He does.” “Now, if he is expelled and then returns in defiance of his enemies, will he not return as a finished tyrant?” “Evidently.” “But if they are unable to expel him or to have him killed by spreading slander in the city, they conspire to have him slain in secret and die a violent death.” “Yes,” said he, “that is what tends to happen.” “Then comes the request of the tyrant, all too familiar, the one that they all come up with at this stage. They ask the people for some bodyguards so that the saviour of the people may be kept safe for them.” “Indeed so,” said he.

566c

“And they grant his request, I believe, because they are afraid on his behalf, although they are confident about their own situation.” “Yes, indeed.” “Now, when the man with money sees all this – a man who, besides having money, is accused of hating the common people – then, my friend, as the oracle given to Croesus says,

*He flees along the shore of many-pebbled Hermus
He abides not, nor is he ashamed to be a coward.*¹¹⁰

“Indeed,” said he, “he will not get a second chance to be ashamed.” “And I imagine,” said I, “that he is done to death if he gets caught.”

566d

“Inevitably.” “And yet that protector of the people does not of course lie fallen, ‘a great man brought down in his greatness’.¹¹¹ No, he overthrows numerous adversaries, and stands in the controlling position of the city, a complete tyrant rather than a

mere protector.” “It must be so,” said he. “Should we,” said I, “give an account of the happiness of this man and of the city in which such a creature has arisen?” “Yes, certainly,” said he. “Let us give the account.”

566e

“Well,” said I, “initially, in the early days, does he not have a smile and a warm greeting for anyone he meets? Does he not deny that he is a tyrant and make lots of promises in private and in public, free people from their debts, and distribute land to the people and to his own circle, and does he not pretend to be kind and gentle to everyone?” “He must,” said he. “And yet I believe once he is reconciled with some of his enemies in exile, and has destroyed the others, and all is quiet in that regard, he sets about waging some war or other constantly so that the people will be in need of a leader.” “Quite likely.”

567a

“He does this so that they will also be impoverished by paying taxes, forced to focus upon their day-to-day needs, and be less inclined to conspire against him.” “Obviously.” “And if he suspects that some people with exalted notions of freedom will not accept his authority, I believe he can come up with a pretext to destroy these people by handing them over to the enemy. So, for all these reasons it is imperative that a tyrant stirs up war continuously.” “Imperative.” “And because he behaves like this, must he not expect to be increasingly hated by the citizens?” “How can he not expect that?”

567b

“And will not some of those who helped him to power, and are in power themselves, speak frankly to him and to one another, criticising the things that are happening – those who are brave enough to do so at any rate.” “Quite likely.” “So, the tyrant needs to do away with all these people secretly if he is to have authority, until finally there is no one left, friend or foe, who is of any use to him.” “Evidently.”

567c

“So, he must keep a sharp eye out to see who is courageous, who has a great mind, who is intelligent, and who is wealthy. And such is his blessedness that whether he likes it or not, he must be an enemy to all these people, and conspire against them, until such time as he cleanses the city.” “A fine cleansing that is,” said he. “Yes,” said I, “it is the exact opposite of what physicians do to bodies. They remove the worst and leave the best, but the tyrant does the opposite.” “Yes,” said he. “It seems he needs to do this if he is to rule the city.”

567d

“So, he is bound,” said I, “by a blessed necessity which directs him either to live alongside people who are, for the most part, quite ordinary, or else not live at all.” “He is,” said he. “Now, is it not the case that the more he is hated by the citizens for doing all this, the greater his need for more bodyguards who are more trustworthy?” “He has no alternative.” “So, who are these trustworthy people? And where will he source them from?” “Lots of them will fly in of their own accord,” said he, “once he comes up with the money.”

567e

“By the dog,” said I, “I think you are referring to some more drones, foreign ones this time, of all varieties.” “Yes,” said he. “I think that is true.” “What about local ones? Would he be at all reluctant to take the slaves away from the citizens, set them free, and then make them part of his own circle of bodyguards?” “He will be very keen to do so,” he said, “since men like this will be extremely loyal to him.” “What a blessed thing this tyranny is,” said I, “if it relies upon such people as trusted friends, having done away with their predecessors.” “But of course he relies on people like this,” said he.

568a

“And these companions of his admire him, of course,” said I. “And the new citizens associate with him, while the respectable

citizens hate him and avoid him.” “What else could they do?” “It is no wonder,” said I, “that tragedy is generally thought to be wise, and Euripides is thought to excel in it.” “Why so?” “Because he uttered the following maxim, born of cogent thought: ‘tyrants are wise, by associating with the wise’. And he meant of course that these people, with whom the tyrant is associating, are wise people.”

568b

“And,” said he, “he praises the tyranny as the equal of the gods, and he himself says much else besides, as do the other poets.” “And that,” said I, “is why the tragic poets, being wise, forgive us and those with a form of government similar to ours for not admitting them, because they are advocates of tyranny.” “I think,” said he, “that the more civilised among them do forgive us.”

568c

“And yet, I believe, they go around the other cities, and by gathering crowds and paying for the services of good voices that are loud and persuasive, they influence those regimes in the direction of tyranny or democracy.” “They do indeed.” “And besides this, will they not receive payment and be honoured too, mostly, as seems likely, by tyrannical regimes and, to a lesser extent, by democracies? But the higher they climb along the ascending scale of systems of government, the more their honour starts to flag, as if it were unable to go any further because it was out of breath.” “Yes, indeed.”

568d

“But we have digressed here,” said I. “Let us go back to that noble, numerous, variegated and ever-changing army of the tyrant, and say how it is supported.” “Obviously,” said he, “if there are sacred treasures in the city’s temples he will spend these for as long as the proceeds from their sale is sufficient, and make the people contribute less.” “And what happens when this runs out?” “Obviously,” said he, “he himself, his fellow

drinkers and his companions, both male and female, will be supported from his father's estate."

568e

"I understand," said I. "The people who brought forth this tyrant will support the man himself and his companions too." "They need to," said he, "very much so." "What are you saying?" I asked. "What if the people get angry and say that it is unjust for a grown-up son to be supported by his father, and that it should be the other way around – the father should be supported by the son? That was not why they created him and put him in place, so that when ^{569a} he had grown up the people would then be enslaved by their own slaves and end up supporting him, along with the slaves and a rabble of others too. They wanted to be liberated from the wealthy classes and the so-called 'noble and good' people in their own city, with him as their protector. What if they now order him to get out of the city, himself and his companions, like a father driving an errant son out of the house along with a rabble of revellers?"

569b

"By Zeus," said he, "the people would then realise what sort of beast they had brought forth, embraced and encouraged. They are now the weaker party driving out someone stronger." "What do you mean?" said I. "Would the tyrant dare to do violence to his father and aim a blow at him if he was not compliant?" "Yes," said he, "after he had disarmed him." "You are saying," said I, "that the tyrant is a parricide and a harsh nurturer of the aged, and it seems that this would indeed be undisguised tyranny. And, as the saying goes, in fleeing from the ^{569c} smoke of slavery to free men, the people would have fallen into the fire of total subjugation to slaves. Instead of that vast and immoderate freedom, they have donned a new robe, the harshest and most bitter slavery, slavery to slaves." "Yes, that is what happens," said he, "very much so." "Well, then," said I, "would it be appropriate for us to claim that we have

given a sufficiently detailed account of how tyranny follows after democracy, and what it is like then?" "Sufficiently detailed indeed," said he.

BOOK IX

571a

"Then," said I, "what remains to be considered is the tyrannical man himself, how he develops from the democratic man and what he is like then, and whether his manner of life is wretched or blessed." "Yes," said he, "this fellow remains to be considered." "I feel that something is still missing," said I. "Do you know what it is?" "What?" "I do not think we have adequately distinguished the kind and number of the various desires. Indeed, if we do not remedy this deficiency, the search we are engaged in will lack clarity." "Would not this still be a good time to do so?" said he.

571b

"Yes, certainly. And consider what I wish to see in these desires. It is as follows. Among the unnecessary pleasures and desires, some I believe are lawless. Although these are probably innate in everyone, they can nevertheless, when restrained by the laws and by the better desires accompanied by reason, be eliminated completely in some cases, or a few weak ones may be left. But in other cases those that remain may be stronger and more numerous." "Can you say," said he, "what these desires are?"

571c

"Those," said I, "that are aroused whenever the rational, gentle part of the soul, the part that rules the other part, is in slumber, and the brutish and wild part, gorged on food or wine, springs to life, refusing to sleep, and sets out to indulge its bad habits. You know that in a situation like this, it ^{571d} dares to do anything at all, as if it had been released from and was rid of all shame and understanding. Indeed, it does not shrink, or so it imagines,

from intercourse with mother or with anything else at all, man or god or beast. It murders anyone at all and eats any meat at all, without restraint, and in short there is no deed, be it mindless or shameless, that it leaves undone.” “Very true,” said he.

571e

“And yet I think when someone keeps himself healthy and of sound mind, and goes to sleep having aroused the rational part of himself, and feasted it on beautiful words and considerations, he attains concord with himself. He ensures that his appetitive part is neither in want nor fully satisfied so ^{572a} that it may be lulled to sleep and not be a source of trouble to the best part of him by being pleased or in pain, but will allow that part, just by itself, to reflect on its own and aspire to perceive what it does not know of the past, the present or the future. “He calms the spirited part too in the same way, and he will not go to sleep with a troubled heart after being angry with someone. Rather, having quietened the other two parts and activated the third, the one in which understanding resides, he then takes his rest. You know that under such circumstances he is most likely to apprehend the truth, and the visions that appear in his dreams are then least likely to be lawless.” “That is it,” said he, “entirely so.”

572b

“Well, all of this has led us to say more than we needed to, but what we want to recognise is this: that there is, in fact, some fearsome, savage and lawless form of desires present in each of us, even in some people who seem to be extremely moderate, and this becomes evident when we are asleep. So, think about whether I am making any sense and whether you agree.” “Yes, I agree.”

572c

“Well, remember the democratic man, and what we said he was like. He presumably became like this by being brought up from

his earliest years by a miserly father who only had respect for those desires that make money and had no respect for the unnecessary ones that exist for the sake of amusement and ostentation. Is this so?" "Yes."

572d

"But once he associates with cleverer men who are full of the desires we have just described, he rushes in the direction of total excess, adopts the behaviour of those new-found friends, and hates the miserliness of his father. But because he is by nature better than his corruptors, he is drawn in both directions and finally takes up a middle position in between the two tendencies. Managing – so he believes anyway – to enjoy each of them in due measure, he lives a life that is neither devoid of freedom nor utterly lawless. He has been transformed from an oligarchical man into a democratic one." "Yes," said he, "this was, and remains, our view of such a person."

572e

"Then, assume once again," said I, "that a man like this has already grown older, and has a young son who has, in turn, been brought up in the habits of his father." "I am assuming this." "Assume too that the same things that happened to his father also happen to the son. He is drawn to utter lawlessness, which is called total freedom by those who are leading him. His father and other relatives assist those middle desires, while his corruptors, in turn, help the other desires. And when these clever beguilers and tyrant-makers lose hope of controlling the young man by any ^{573a} other means, they contrive to engender a passion in him, as a protector of the idle desires that are keen to spend so freely. And the passion in such people is a huge, winged drone. Or do you think it is something else?" "No, I do not think it is anything else," said he.

573b

"Now, when the other desires are buzzing about the drone, full of incense, perfume, garlands and wine, and all the pleasures

that are usually let loose at such gatherings, they feed the drone and make it grow, and engender in it the sting of desire. Then this protector of the soul, with madness as its bodyguard, goes into a frenzy, and if it detects any opinions or desires within itself that are accounted worthy, or still have any shame, it kills them off and pushes them out of itself until it has been cleansed of sound-mindedness and is full of madness brought in from outside.”

573c

“That,” said he, “is a comprehensive description of the origin of the tyrannical man.” “Is this not why Eros has traditionally been called a tyrant?” said I. “Quite likely,” said he. “And, my friend,” said I, “does not a man who is drunk have a certain tyrannical frame of mind?” “He has.” “And, indeed, someone who is mad or deranged endeavours to exercise authority, not only over men but over gods too, and he imagines that he can do so.” “Very much so,” said he.

573d

“And this, dear fellow, is exactly how a man becomes tyrannical,” said I. “It happens when, by nature or by his pursuits, or both, he has become drunken, passionate and maniacal.” “Entirely so.” “That, it seems, is how the man originates and that is what he is like. But how then does he live?” “You tell me!” said he, as people say when they are having fun. “I shall,” said I. “Indeed, I believe that after this they indulge in feasting, carousing, revelry and womanising, and all sorts of things associated with people whose entire soul is governed by an indwelling tyrannical passion.” “Inevitably,” said he. “Now, do not desires, many and fearsome, spring up alongside this one, every day and every night, making many demands?” “Many indeed.” “So, any sources of income are quickly spent.” “Of course.”

573e

“And after this comes borrowing and the erosion of his estate.” “Indeed.” “And when all this fails him, must not there be an outcry from that crowd of intense desires that have made their nest there? Must not the men themselves be goaded on, so to speak, by the stings of the other desires, and especially by the master-passion itself which leads all the others as if they were its bodyguards? Will they not look about in a frenzy to see who has something that can be taken away by deception or by force?” “Very much so,” said he.

574a

“So, he needs to plunder from every quarter, or else be gripped by enormous travails and pains.” “He must.” “Now, just as the newer pleasures in him got the better of the old ones and took away all they possessed, so too would not the man himself also, in spite of his youth, feel that he deserves to have more than his father and mother, and to take away and appropriate the family’s wealth, once he had spent his own portion?” “Yes, indeed,” said he.

574b

“And if they would not turn it over to him, would he not initially attempt to steal from his parents and deceive them?” “Absolutely.” “And if he were unable to do this, would he then seize what he could by force?” “I think so,” said he. “And then, my friend, if that elderly man or woman resisted him and put up a fight, would he be careful and spare them from any tyrannical behaviour?” “No,” said he, “I am not at all confident about the fate of the parents of a man like this.”

574c

“But, by Zeus, Adimantus, do you think he would rain down blows upon his aged friend, the friend he needs, his own mother, all because of a new-found girlfriend, a companion he does not need? Would he strike his elderly father, a man in decline, a much-needed and most ancient friend, all because of a newfound boyfriend in his prime whom he does not really

need? And would he let his parents be slaves of these new friends if he were to bring them all into the same household?" "Yes, he would, by Zeus," said he. "How very blessed it seems to be," said I, "to bring forth a tyrannical son." "Entirely so," said he.

574d

"But what happens to such a person when the resources of his father and mother fail him, while the swarm of pleasures within him is already growing in size? Will he not initially turn his hand to house-breaking or steal the robe of someone who is out late at night, and then go on to plunder a temple? And in all these exploits, the opinions he held of old since childhood about what is noble and what is shameful, opinions that are accounted just, will be subject to those opinions, newly released from slavery, that constitute the bodyguards of the ruling passion and rule alongside it.

574e

These were released previously only in dreams during sleep, when he was still subject to the laws and to his father, because he was under democratic rule within. But now that he is under the tyranny of passion, the sort of person he occasionally became whilst dreaming is the sort of person he has ^{575a} now become, constantly, whilst awake. He will not refrain from any vile murder; there is nothing he will not eat, no action he will not perform. Passion lives within him as a tyrant, in total anarchy and lawlessness, since it is itself the sole ruler, and like a tyrant in a city it will lead anyone in whom it resides to utter recklessness. From this it feeds itself and the rabble that surrounds it, some of which come in from outside from bad company, some of which come from within because the very same tendencies, his own tendencies in this case, have been established and set free. Is this not the life that a man like this leads?" "That is it, indeed," said he.

575b

“And,” said I, “if people of this sort are few in number while the rest of the population of the city is sound-minded, they leave and act as bodyguards for some other tyrant, or serve as paid mercenaries in time of war. But if they arise in time of peace when things are quiet, they stay in the city and do a lot of bad deeds on a small scale.” “What sort of deeds?” “Theft, for instance, house-breaking, picking pockets, stealing people’s clothes, robbing from temples and kidnapping. And sometimes, if they are accomplished speakers, they become informers, give false evidence and take bribes.” “Yes,” said he, “small-scale bad deeds indeed, provided such people are few in number.”

575c

“Yes,” said I, “what is small is small relative to what is large, and none of these evils ‘come nigh at all’, as they say, to a tyrant in terms of the corruption and degeneracy of a city. For when such people grow large in number in the city, along with the others who follow their lead, and they realise how numerous they are, these are the ones who, with assistance from the unthinking general populace, bring forth that tyrant, the particular person who has the greatest and most extensive tyrant within his own soul.” “Yes, quite likely,” said he, “since he would be the most tyrannical of them all.”

575d

“That is what happens if the people yield willingly, but if the city will not submit to him, then he acts as he did towards his own father and mother. He will punish his fatherland in the same way that he punished them, if he can, by bringing in his newfound companions, and he will hold and maintain his beloved ancient fatherland – or motherland, as the Cretans say – in slavery to them. And this would be the culmination of such a man’s desire.” “It would,” said he, “entirely so.”

575e

“Well, then,” said I, “how do these people behave as private citizens, even before they have authority? In the first place, will

they not spend their time with people who flatter them when they are together, or who are prepared to do anything to serve them? Or if they want something from someone else, will they not debase themselves and try any device, as if they were friends, but turn into strangers once their mission is accomplished?" "Yes, very much so."

576a

"And so they live their entire lives without ever being friends to anyone, but always either someone's master or someone else's slave. But the tyrannical nature never gets a taste of true freedom or true friendship." "Entirely so." "Well then, would we be right to refer to such people as unfaithful?" "Of course." "And unjust too, to the greatest extent possible, if we were indeed correct in agreeing what we agreed previously about the sort of thing justice is." "Well, we were right about that at any rate," said he.

576b

"To sum up, then," said I, "let us say this about the most evil person: he would presumably, even when awake, be like the sort of person we described in dreams." "Yes, certainly." "And he comes into existence when someone who is by nature utterly tyrannical, has sole authority, and the longer he lives the life of a tyrant, the more like this he becomes." "He must," said Glaucon, taking up the argument.

576c

"So, is it the case," said I, "that whoever proves to be most evil will also prove to be most wretched? And is it the case that whoever is a tyrant to the greatest degree for the most time, has in truth been most miserable for the most time? But popular opinion on this is quite varied." "Well, the situation must be as you describe it," said he. "And does not the tyrannical man correspond to the tyrannically governed city in likeness," I said, "and the democratic man to the democratically governed city, and similarly for the others?" "Of course."

576d

“Now, as city corresponds to city in excellence and happiness, does one man correspond to another man in this respect too?” “Of course.” “Now, in terms of excellence, how does the city governed by a tyrant correspond to the first one we described, the one governed by a king?” “It is the complete opposite,” said he. “Indeed, one is the most excellent of all and the other is the worst.”

576e

“I shall not ask,” said I, “which you are referring to since it is quite obvious. But would your decision be the same in relation to happiness and wretchedness, or would it be different? And let us not be dazzled by looking at the tyrant in person or a few people in his inner circle; we need to look at the whole city by going into it, delving into every corner and seeing what is there. Then and only then may we express our opinion.” “You are right to challenge me,” said he. “Indeed, it is obvious to everyone that no city is more wretched than one that is governed by a tyrant, and none is more happy than one that is governed by a king.”

577a

“Well,” said I, “what if I were to issue the very same challenges in relation to individual men? Would I be right to suggest that the only person who has the right to decide these issues is someone who is able to use his mind to go deep into the character of a man and see clearly, without being dazzled by the pretence of the tyrannical types, like a child who looks only from the outside, someone who is well able to see through the pretence that tyrants put on for the world at large? Now, what if I were to presume that we should all listen to that person, the one who is able to make this decision and who has lived alongside a tyrant and has witnessed his dealings with his household and how he behaves towards the various members of his family where he is best seen, stripped of ^{577b} theatrical

trappings, and who has also seen him amidst the perils of public life? Since this person has seen so much, should we call upon him to report where the tyrant stands relative to the others, in terms of happiness and wretchedness?" "You would," said he, "be absolutely right to suggest this." "Would you like us," said I, "to pretend to be people who are able to make this decision, and who have already met up with tyrants, so that we may have someone to answer the questions we asked?" "Certainly."

577c

"Come on, then," said I, "and consider the following. Remembering the similarity between the city and the individual man, consider them carefully, each in turn, and describe the characteristics of each." "What sort of characteristics?" he asked. "Firstly," said I, "to speak of the city, will you say that the one governed by a tyrant is free or enslaved?" "Enslaved," said he, "to the greatest extent possible." "And yet you see masters and free men there."

577d

"Yes," said he, "I see this, and it is a small detail, but the whole population, so to speak, in that city, and the very best part, is dishonourably and miserably enslaved." "Now," said I, "if the individual is like the city, must not the same state of affairs prevail within him, and must not his soul be full of slavishness and restriction, the very best parts being enslaved, while a small part, the worst and the maddest, is their master?" "It must be so," said he. "In that case, will you maintain that a soul of this sort is enslaved or free?" "Enslaved, I presume."

577e

"Furthermore, does not the enslaved, tyrannically governed city do what it wishes to do to the least possible extent?" "Yes, the very least."

578a

"So, the tyrannically governed soul, too, will do what it wishes to do to the least possible extent, speaking of the soul as a

whole, and, being continually impelled by the gadfly of desire, it will be full of confusion and regret.” “Inevitably.” “And must the tyrannically governed city be wealthy or poor?” “Poor.” “So the tyrannical soul too must always be in need and dissatisfied.” “It must,” said he. “And what about this? Must not a city like this and a person like this be full of fear?” “That is quite inevitable.”

578b

“And do you think you will find more wailing, groaning, lamentation and suffering in any other city than you find in this one?” “Not at all.” “And do you think this sort of thing is more prevalent in any other individual than it is in this tyrant, mad with desires and passions?” “How could I?” he said.

578c

“Now, I imagine you decided that this city, at any rate, is the most wretched of cities in view of all these considerations and others like them.” “Was I not right to do so?” he asked. “Very much so,” said I. “But what do you say, in turn, about the tyrannical individual in the light of these same considerations?” “That he is”, said he, “the most wretched by far, more so than any of the others.” “That,” said I, “is not quite correct.” “How so?” he asked. “This fellow,” said I, “is not yet the most wretched I imagine.” “Then who is?” “Someone who will surely seem to you to be more wretched than this fellow.” “Who?”

578d

“Someone,” said I, “with a tyrannical nature who does not live out his life as a private citizen, but by an unfortunate accident gets the opportunity to become an actual tyrant.” “I reckon,” said he, “from what has already been said, that this is true.” “Yes,” said I, “but we should not merely think about matters of this sort. We should consider them very carefully, using an argument like this, since our enquiry is concerned with the most important issue of all – living a good life or a bad one.” “Quite right,” said he. “Now, consider if what I am saying makes

any sense. For I think this needs to be considered with the following examples in mind.” “What examples?”

578e

“The example of any of the private citizens in the city who are wealthy and own lots of slaves, for they have this in common with tyrants: they rule over many people, although they differ in that the tyrant rules over a greater number.” “They differ in this way, indeed.” “And you know, do you not, that these people do not live in fear and they are not terrified of their own household slaves?” “Yes, for what would they be afraid of?” “Nothing,” said I. “But do you recognise the reason why?” “Yes, because the entire city is there to assist every single private citizen.” “That is right,” said I. “But what if some god were to take one man who owned fifty slaves or even more, lift him and his wife and children out of the city and set him down in an isolated place, along with his other property and his household slaves, where none of his fellow free men would be in a position to come to his aid? Can you imagine his fear, and how afraid he would be that he, his children and his wife might be done away with by his own slaves?” “I think he would be in total fear,” said he.

579a

“Would he not be compelled, at that stage, to ingratiate himself with some of those slaves, make lots of promises, and even set them free when there was no need to, and he himself would thus turn out to be the flatterer of his own servants.” “He would have to do that,” said he, “just to survive.” “And what if the god,” said I, “were to settle other people around him, lots of neighbours who would not put up with it if someone were to claim the right to enslave anyone else, and would inflict the most severe punishments on someone who acts like this, if they could catch him?” “I think,” said he, “that he would be in even more difficulty, in every respect, being watched from all sides by nothing but enemies.”

579b

“So, is it not the case that the tyrant is bound fast in a prison house like this, since his nature is as we have described it, filled with a huge variety of fears and passions? Although his soul is full of craving, he is the one person in the city who finds it impossible to travel abroad or to see anything that other free men love to see. Skulking inside his own house most of the time, does he not live ^{579c} like a woman, envying the other citizens if any of them ever travel abroad or see anything good?” “Yes, entirely so,” said he. “So, does not the man who is ill-governed within, the tyrannical man whom you deemed most wretched, reap an even greater harvest of such evils once he forsakes his private life and is compelled by some chance event to become a tyrant, and attempts to rule others when he cannot even control himself? It is as if someone with a sick body that cannot control itself was compelled to ^{579d} live his life not in quiet privacy, but in constant competition and physical combat.” “Very true, Socrates,” said he, “it is exactly like that.” “Now, dear Glaucon,” said I, “is this not an entirely wretched predicament, and does not the actual tyrant live an even harsher life than the person whose life you decided was harshest?” “Definitely,” said he.

579e

“So, the truth of the matter, even if someone thinks otherwise, is that the real tyrant is actually a slave to fawning and servitude on a huge scale, and a flatterer of the most vile people of all. Since none of his desires are satisfied, he turns out to be most needy in most respects, and in truth, poor, once someone knows how to look at a soul as a whole. He is full of fear too throughout his entire life, beset with convulsions and pains, if he does indeed resemble the disposition of the city he rules over. And he does resemble this, does he not?” “Very much so,” said he.

580a

“And in addition to all this, should we not also ascribe what we spoke of earlier to this man? Must he not be envious, unfaithful, unjust, friendless and impious, a host and nurturer of every evil? And must he not become even more like this than he previously was because he is a ruler, and for all these reasons be most unhappy in himself and make people around him unhappy too?” “No one,” said he, “with any intelligence will argue against you.”

580b

“Come on now,” said I, “act like the overall judge in a competition and announce who, in your opinion, comes first in terms of happiness, who comes second, and so on for the other five in turn, the kingly person, the timocratic, the oligarchic, the democratic and the tyrannical. Decide!” “The decision is an easy one,” said he. “I judge them as if I were judging theatrical choruses, and I rank them in terms of excellence and evil, happiness and its opposite, in the very order in which they made their entrance.”

580c

“Shall we hire a herald then?” I asked. “Or shall I myself proclaim that the son of Ariston has decided that the best and most just person is also the happiest, and this is the most kingly person who exercises kingly rule over himself, and that the worst and most unjust person is also the most wretched, and he, for his part, turns out to be the most tyrannical person who tyrannises to the greatest possible extent over himself, and over the city too?” “Consider it done,” said he. “And should I declare, in addition,” said I, “that this is the case whether their dispositions are noticed by all men and gods, or not?” “Add that declaration,” said he.

580d

“So be it,” said I, “and this would be one of our proofs. But take a look at a second one and see if you think it amounts to anything.” “What is it?” “Since the city,” said I, “is divided into

three parts, and the soul of each individual is threefold in like manner, this I believe will afford another proof.” “In what way?”

580e

“As follows. It seems to me that there are three kinds of pleasures corresponding to the three parts of the soul, one pleasure being particular to each part, and that the same goes for desires and for ways of ruling the soul.” “What do you mean?” he asked. “There is, according to us, one part with which a person learns, and another with which he becomes spirited. We were unable to provide a particular name for the third since it is complex, so we named it after its largest and strongest aspect. We called it the appetitive part, due to the intensity of its appetite for food, drink and sex, and everything associated with these. We called it money-loving too, because such appetites are satisfied mainly through money.”

581a

“And we were right to do so,” said he. “Well then, if we were to say that the pleasure and love belonging to this part was for profit, would that best summarise the argument so that we could be confident that we are referring to this part of the soul correctly when we refer to it as money-loving or profit-loving?” “So it seems to me anyway,” said he. “What about this? Do we not maintain that the spirited part is always wholly intent upon power, victory and fame?” “Very much so.” “Now, if we were to refer to it as ambitious and in love with honour, would that seem right?” “Right indeed.”

581b

“But, of course, it is obvious to everyone that the part by which we learn is always intent upon knowing the truth as it is, and, of the three parts, this one is least interested in money and reputation.” “The least by far.” “Would it be appropriate then for us to refer to it as having a love of learning and of wisdom?”

581c

“Yes, of course.” “Is it not the case,” said I, “that this part rules the soul of some people while one of the other two rules the souls of others, as the case may be?” “Quite so,” said he. “For these reasons, then, we say that the principal kinds of human being are also three in number: the kind that loves wisdom, the kind that loves winning and the kind that loves profit.” “Exactly.” “And are there not three forms of pleasure, one underlying each of these?” “Entirely so.”

581d

“Now you do realise, do you not,” said I, “that if you decided to ask three people of this sort, each in turn, which of these lives is most pleasant, each would praise his own way of life the most? Will not the money-maker maintain that unless he makes some money from them, the pleasures of attaining honour or learning are worthless in comparison with the pleasure of making profit?” “True,” said he. “What about the kind that loves honour?” I asked. “Will he not regard the pleasure that comes from money as vulgar, and the pleasure that comes from learning, for its part, as insubstantial nonsense unless the learning confers some honour?” “That is his position,” said he.

581e

“And how,” said I, “do we think the lover of wisdom will regard the other pleasures in comparison with knowing the truth as it is and being continually involved in something like this while he is learning? Will not the other pleasures be far removed from this pleasure, and will he not refer to them as necessary, in a literal sense, because he would have no need for any of them unless necessity was involved?” “This needs to be well understood,” said he.

582a

“Now,” said I, “when there is dispute over the pleasures of each kind and over the life itself, not only over which life is more noble or more shameful, which is worse and which is better, but over which life is actually more pleasant and least painful, how

are we to know which of them is really speaking the truth?" "I just cannot say," he replied. "Well, consider it in this way. What should things be judged by if they are going to be properly judged? Is it not by experience, intelligence and argument, or could anyone have a better criterion than these?" "How could they?" said he.

582b

"Then consider this. Of the three men, who among them has most experience of all the pleasures we mentioned? Does the lover of profit, by understanding truth itself and what it is like, seem to you to have more experience of the pleasure of knowledge than the lover of wisdom has of the pleasure that comes from making a profit?" "There is a big difference," said he. "Indeed the lover of wisdom, of necessity, tastes the other pleasures from his earliest childhood. But there is no necessity that the lover of profit tastes the pleasure of learning the nature of things that are, and how sweet that pleasure is, or that he have any experience of this, and even if he is eager to do so, it is not easy." "There is a big difference, then," said I, "between the lover of wisdom and the lover of profit in their experience of both of these pleasures." "Big, indeed."

582c

"And how does he compare to the lover of honour? Does the lover of wisdom have less experience of the pleasure of attaining honour than the profit lover has of the pleasure of the intellect?" "No," said he, "honour accrues to them all once they achieve whatever they are each intent upon. Indeed, the wealthy are honoured by lots of people, and so too are the courageous and the wise. So they all have experience of the kind of pleasure that comes from attaining honour. But it is impossible for anyone except the lover of wisdom to have tasted the kind of pleasure that comes from beholding what is."

582d

“So, in terms of experience,” said I, “he is a better judge than any of the others.” “Much better.” “And, indeed, he alone will have gained his experience in the company of intelligence.” “Indeed.” “Then again, the instrument that is needed in order to judge is not the instrument of the profit lover, or of the lover of honour, but of the lover of wisdom.” “What is it?” “I think we said that it is necessary to judge by means of arguments. Is this so?” “Yes.” “And arguments are the instrument of the philosopher most of all.” “They must be.” “Now, if whatever is to be judged were best judged by wealth and profit, then the things that the profit lover praised and censured would necessarily be the truest of all, would they not?” “Much the truest.” “And if they were judged by honour, victory and courage, would not whatever is praised by the ambitious lover of honour be truest?” “Obviously.”

582e

“But since they must be judged by experience, intelligence and argument, what follows?” “It must be the case,” said he, “that whatever the lover of wisdom and argument praises is the truest.” “So, of the three pleasures, would the one that belongs to the part of the soul we learn with be most pleasant, and would the life of the person in whom this part rules be the most pleasant life of the three?” “How could it be otherwise?” said he. “The man of intelligence is the one who has complete authority to praise his own life.” “And what life comes second and what pleasure comes second, according to the judge?” I asked. “It is obviously the pleasure of the military type who loves honour since this is closer to the lover of wisdom than the pleasure of the lover of profit.” “Then it seems that the pleasure of the lover of profit comes last.” “Indeed,” said he.

583a

“These would constitute two arguments in succession, and two victories for the just over the unjust. Let the third, in Olympic fashion, be dedicated to the Saviour, Olympian Zeus. Consider

this carefully. The pleasure of the others, apart from the pleasure of the man of intelligence, is not completely true, nor is it pure; it is a mere shadow-drawing, as it seems to me I have heard from one of the wise. And, indeed, this next overthrow of the unjust would be the greatest and most decisive of all.” “Very decisive. But what do you mean?” “I will discover this,” said I, “if you answer questions while I carry out an enquiry.” “Ask your questions then,” said he.

583b

“Then tell me,” said I, “do we not maintain that pain is the opposite of pleasure?” “Very much so.” “And do we not also say that being neither in pleasure nor in pain is possible?” “It is indeed.” “Would you describe this as a middle state, between these two, a respite of the soul from both?” “Quite so.”

583c

“Now,” said I, “do you recall the utterances of sick people and what they say when they are ill?” “What sort of utterances?”

583d

“That nothing is actually more pleasant than being healthy, but they were unaware, prior to their illness, just how pleasant it is.” “I remember,” said he. “And do you not hear people who are gripped by some huge pain saying that nothing is more pleasant than cessation of pain?” “I do hear that.” “And I believe in lots of other situations like this, you notice that people in pain, rather than praising enjoyment, praise absence of pain and respite from this sort of thing as the greatest pleasure.” “Yes,” said he, “this respite is probably pleasant and enjoyable then.”

583e

“And,” said I, “when someone’s enjoyment comes to an end, respite from the pleasure will be a source of pain.” “Probably,” said he. “So respite, which we said just now is in between pleasure and pain, will on occasion be both.” “So it seems.” “But is it possible for something that is neither to become both?” “I do not think so.” “And, indeed, the pleasure that arises in the

soul, and the pain too, are both movements of some sort, are they not?" "Yes."

584a

"And did not whatever is neither painful nor pleasant turn out just now to be a repose between these two?" "So it did." "Now, how could it be right to think that not being in pain is pleasure, and absence of enjoyment is pain?" "It could not be." "So this is not the case," said I, "but it appears so. Respite, on occasion, appears pleasant in comparison with pain, and painful in comparison with pleasure, but there is nothing sound in any of these appearances in relation to the truth about pleasure. They are, rather, a sort of enchantment." "Well," said he, "that is what the argument is indicating."

584b

"Then," said I, "look at the pleasures that do not originate in pains, so that you do not come to believe, in the present case, that this is the natural state of affairs, that pleasure is indeed the cessation of pain, and pain the cessation of pleasure." "Where shall I look," said he, "and what sort of pleasures do you mean?" "Well," said I, "although there are many other examples, I would like you to pay particular attention to the pleasures associated with smells. For these suddenly become extraordinarily intense, without any preceding pain, and when they cease they leave no pain at all behind." "Very true," said he.

584c

"So, let us not believe that being quit of pain is pure pleasure, or that being quit of pleasure is pain." "Let us not." "And yet," said I, "the greatest and most numerous of the so-called pleasures that extend through the body as far as the soul, are of this form. They are mere releases from pain." "They are, indeed." "And does not the same hold for the anticipatory pleasures and pains that arise from our expectations of these?" "The same, indeed."

584d

“Now,” said I, “do you know what qualities they have, and what they most resemble?” “What?” he asked. “Do you think,” said I, “that in nature there is an up, a down and a middle?” “I do.” “Now, do you think that someone being carried from below towards the middle would think he is being carried upwards? Could he think otherwise? And once he is standing in the middle, looking back to where he had been carried from, would he not presume without question that he is above, never having seen the truly above?” “By Zeus,” said he, “I really do not think a person in such a position could think otherwise.”

584e

“And if he were carried back again,” said I, “would he think he was being carried down, and would that be true?” “How could it not be?” “And would not all this happen because he has no experience of what is truly above, in the middle, and below?” “Obviously.” “And would you be at all surprised if people who, in like manner, have no experience of the truth about many other matters, hold unsound opinions? Might they hold a view of pleasure and pain, and the intermediate state according to which, when they move in the direction of pain, they think they really and truly are in pain? But on the other hand, when they move from pain to the intermediate state, might they be convinced that they are approaching fulfilment and pleasure, and be deceived by comparing an absence of pain to pain, without any experience of pleasure, as if they were comparing black to grey with no experience of white?” “By Zeus,” said he, “I would not be surprised. No, I would be much more surprised if this did not happen.”

585a

“Well, think about this,” said I. “Are not hunger and thirst and the like a sort of deficiency in the state of the body?” “Indeed.” “And are not ignorance and stupidity, in turn, a deficiency in the state of the soul?” “Very much so.” “And would not anyone who gets nourishment or who acquires intelligence be filled

up?” “Of course.”

585b

“And does the true filling up involve being filled with what is less real or more real?” “With what is more real, of course.” “And which of the kinds do you think partakes more of pure being? Is it the kind that includes food, drink, relish and every kind of nourishment, or the form that includes true opinion, knowledge, intelligence and, in short, all excellence? You need to decide the following question. Does that which holds to the unchanging, to the immortal and to truth, and is like this itself and originates in something like this, seem more real to you than what holds to the ever-changing and the mortal, and is like this itself and originates in this sort of thing?”

585c

“Whatever holds to that which is unchanging,” said he, “far exceeds the other.” “Now, does the being of the unchanging partake any more of being than of knowledge?” “Not at all.” “Or of truth?” “Not of truth either.” “And what partakes less of truth, also partakes less of being, does it not?” “Necessarily.” “So, in general, do not the kinds that are concerned with the care of the body partake less of truth and being than those that are concerned with the care of the soul?” “Much less.”

585d

“And do you not think the same holds for the body itself, in comparison with the soul?” “I do indeed.” “So, is not that which is filled with what is more real, and is itself more real, actually filled to a greater extent than something filled with what is less real, and is itself less real?” “It must be.”

585e

“In that case, if being filled with what naturally belongs to us is pleasure, then that which is filled more with things that really are, would make us enjoy true pleasure more really and more truly. But that which shares in things that are less real would be filled less truly and less certainly, and would share in a pleasure

that is less trustworthy and less true.” “This must be so,” said he.

586a

“So, those with no experience of wisdom or excellence, who are constantly involved in feasting and the like, are, it seems, moving downwards and then back to the middle again, and they spend their lives wandering like this. They have never transcended this and turned their gaze to what is truly above, nor have they ever yet been borne there, nor have they really been filled with what is or tasted pleasure that is certain and true.

586b

“Rather, like cattle with a constant downward gaze and their heads bowed towards the ground to their tables, they gorge themselves, feeding then mating, and out of sheer greed for all this, they kick and butt one another with horns and hooves of iron. They slaughter one another with weapons of war because their desire is insatiable, since they are not filling the real part of themselves with things that are, nor are they even filling the part that can contain these.” “Socrates,” said Glaucon, “you are describing most people’s lives in an utterly prophetic manner.”

586c

“Now, is it not inevitable that they live among pleasures that are mixed with pains, mere images and shadow-drawings of true pleasure, taking their colour from being placed alongside one another so that they each appear quite intense, and engender raging passions of their own in senseless people who fight over them, just as the heroes at Troy, according to Stesichorus, fought over the image of Helen, in ignorance of the truth?”¹¹² “Yes,” said he, “something like this is quite inevitable.”

586d

“What about this? Must not similar considerations apply to the spirited part whenever someone satisfies this, either through

envy because he loves honour, or through violence because he is ambitious, or through spirit because he is bad tempered? Is he not then pursuing the satisfaction of honour, victory and spirit, in the absence of and reason and intelligence?" "This sort of thing," said he, "is inevitable too, in that case."

586e

"Well, then," said I, "may we be so bold as to say that in the case of the ambitious, profit-loving part, there are a number of desires that adhere to knowledge and reason, and which pursue their pleasures in the company of these, only adopting those pleasures that intelligence approves of? Will not these desires adopt the truest pleasures they can attain to, because they are following truth itself and pleasures that belong to themselves, if indeed what is best for each is what most belongs to each?" "Yes, what most belongs to each indeed."

587a

"So, when the entire soul follows the lead of the part that loves wisdom, without being rebellious, and each part as a result performs its own function in every respect and is just, then above all does each part reap a rich harvest of pleasures that are its own, the very best pleasures and the very truest of which it is capable?"

587b

"Yes, precisely." "But when any of the other parts is in control, it is unable as a result to discover its own pleasure, and it compels the others to pursue an untrue pleasure that is alien to them." "Quite so," said he. "And would not the parts that stand furthest from philosophy and reason be most inclined to bring this about?" "Yes, they would be most inclined by far." "And whatever stands furthest from reason is furthest from law and from order?" "Of course." "And did not the passionate and tyrannical desires prove to be the ones that stood at the furthest remove?" "Yes, they stood at the furthest remove by far." "And the kingly and orderly desires stood closest?" "Yes."

587c

“Then I suppose the tyrant will stand furthest away from those pleasures that are true and are his own, while the king will stand closest.” “That is necessary.” “Then,” said I, “the tyrant will live the least pleasant life while the king will live the most pleasant one.” “This must be so.” “Now,” said I, “do you know how much less pleasantly the tyrant lives in comparison with a king?” “I would if you told me,” said he. “There are, it seems, three pleasures – one that is genuine, two that are fake. The tyrant has gone beyond the fake pleasures into another realm. Fleeing from law and from reason, he lives with a bodyguard of slavish pleasures, and it is not at all easy to say how much worse off he is, except perhaps in the following way.” “How?” he asked.

587d

“The tyrant, I believe, was at a third remove from the oligarchic type, and the democratic man was in between them.” “Yes.” “And if what we said previously is true, will he not live with an image of pleasure that is at a third remove, in terms of truth, from the oligarch’s pleasure?” “Quite so.” “And yet the oligarchic type is, again, at a third remove from the kingly type if we designate the aristocratic and kingly types as the same.” “A third, indeed.” “So,” said I, “the tyrant stands three times three in number removed from true pleasure.” “So it appears.”

587e

“In that case,” said I, “the image of pleasure that the tyrant has, numerically in terms of length, would, it seems, be a square.” “Precisely.” “And by squaring and cubing, it is obvious what the extent of the interval becomes.” “Of course,” said he, “to a mathematician anyway.” “And if someone does this the other way around and tries to say how far the king stands from the tyrant in terms of the truth of their pleasure, he will find, on completing the calculation, that the king lives 729 times more pleasantly, while the tyrant lives more wretchedly by the very

same interval.” “You have,” said he, “poured forth a massive stream of calculation of the difference between these two men, the just and the unjust, in relation to pleasure and pain.”

588a

“Yes, and it is also a true number, appropriate to their lives,” said I, “if days and nights, months and years are indeed appropriate to them.” “But of course they are appropriate,” said he. “Now, if the good and just man wins out over the bad, unjust man to this extent in terms of pleasure, will he not win out to an enormously greater extent in the refinement of his life and in terms of beauty and excellence?” “Enormously indeed, by Zeus,” said he.

588b

“So be it then,” said I. “Since we have come to this point in the argument, let us go back to the initial statements that got us here. It was said, I believe, that acting unjustly is beneficial to the completely unjust man, provided he has a reputation for being just. Is this not what was said?” “It was, indeed.” “Then,” said I, “let us discuss this now, with its proponent, since we have come to agreement on the power that acting unjustly and doing what is just each possesses.” “How?” said he. “By fashioning an image of the soul in words, so that the person proposing this may see for himself what he is talking about.” “What sort of image?” he asked.

588c

“An image,” said I, “like one of those creatures that are referred to in myths of old – Chimaera, Scylla, Cerberus, and certain others that are spoken of, in which many forms have grown together and become one.” “Yes, so they say,” said he. “Then fashion a single form, the form of a complex, many-headed beast that has heads of wild and tame beasts all in a circle and is able to change all these and make them grow out of itself.” “That is a task for an ingenious craftsman,” said he. “Nevertheless, since it is easier to fashion speech than wax or

the like, let it be fashioned like this.”

588d

“Then fashion one other form, the form of a lion, and then the form of a man, and let the first be the largest by far, and the second, second largest.” “These are easier to fashion,” said he. “It is done.” “Then join these three together into one so that, still being three, they somehow grow together.” “They have been joined,” said he.

588e

“Now fashion an image of one of them round about them all, on the outside, an image of a human being, so that to anyone who is unable to see what is inside and only sees the external shell, it appears to be one creature, a human being.” “The surrounding shell has been fashioned,” said he.

589a

“Then let us say to whoever maintains that acting unjustly is beneficial to this human being, and doing what is just is not advantageous, that he is really claiming that it is beneficial to the person to feed the complex beast well, and make it strong, and the lion too, and its entourage, while he starves his human part and makes it so weak that it is dragged wherever either of the other two may lead it. And it leaves them to themselves to bite, fight with and devour one another rather than getting them accustomed to one another or turning them into friends.” “Absolutely,” said he, “that is just what someone who praises unjust action would be advocating.”

589b

“Then again, would not someone who says that what is just is beneficial be maintaining that it is necessary to do and to say whatever puts the inner human being most in control of the person, whatever ensures that the human part will attend to the many-headed beast, like a husbandman, by nurturing and taming the gentle elements while preventing the wild ones from growing, making an ally of the lion nature, and caring in

common for them all, and making them friends to one another and to itself? Is that not how it will nurture them?"

589c

"Yes, that again is exactly what someone who praises justice asserts." "So, someone who praises justice would be speaking the truth in every respect, while someone who praises what is unjust would be speaking falsehoods. Indeed, from the perspective of pleasure or reputation, or the benefit it confers, whoever praises justice is speaking the truth, while someone who criticises it is unsound in his criticism and does not even know what he is criticising." "Does not know at all, in my view," said he.

589d

"Well, since he is not falling into error deliberately, let us persuade him gently by asking him, 'Good man, would we not say that whatever is regarded as noble or as disgraceful has come to be so for reasons such as these: whatever is noble makes the savage part of our nature subject to the human part, or perhaps to the divine part, and whatever is disgraceful makes the gentle part a slave to the wild part?' Will he agree, or not?" "He will, if he listens to me," said he.

589e

"Now, based on this argument," said I, "is there anyone who benefits from acquiring gold unjustly if, in getting the gold, he enslaves the very best part of himself to the most base part at the same time? Or, if in the process of getting gold he enslaved his own son or daughter to wild and evil men, that would not benefit him no matter how much money he might get for this. But if he enslaves the most divine part of himself to the most godless and corrupt part, and shows no mercy, is he not ^{590a} wretched as a result, and is he not accepting a gift of gold in return for much more terrible ruination than Eriphyle experienced when she took a necklace in return for the soul of her husband?"¹¹³ "Much more terrible indeed," said Glaucon,

“for I will answer your question on his behalf.” “Do you not also think that is why unrestrained behaviour has long been criticised? Is it not because such behaviour lets loose that horror, that huge multiform beast, beyond the proper measure?” “Of course,” said he.

590b

“And wilfulness and discontent are censured, are they not, whenever they cause the lion-like, snake-like part to increase and intensify beyond all proportion?” “Very much so.” “And luxury and softness are censured too, are they not, for loosening and relaxing this same aspect, when they induce cowardice in it?” “Indeed.”

590c

“Are not flattery and servitude censured when someone puts this same spirited aspect in subjection to the unruly beast and degrades the lion, all for the sake of money, to fulfil the beast’s insatiable desires, getting it accustomed from its earliest years to being more of an ape than a lion?” “Indeed so,” said he.

590d

“And why do you think lowly manual labour is subject to reproach? Or is it simply because it is associated with someone whose very best part is, by nature, weak, so that he is unable to rule the beasts within himself, fosters them instead, and is unable to understand anything else except how to flatter them?” “So it seems,” said he.

590e

“Now, so that such a person may be ruled by something similar to what rules the best person, are we to say that he should be a slave of that best person who is ruled by the divine element, and we should not adopt Thrasyarchus’ view that a slave should be ruled to his own detriment? Do we not think it best that everyone be subject to divine wisdom, preferably residing within himself or else established externally, so that we may all be as much alike as possible, and friends too, because we are all

governed by the same thing?” “And rightly so,” said he.

591a

“And the law, being the ally of everyone in the city, makes it clear that it also intends something of this sort. This is also the purpose of the authority we exercise over children, not allowing them to be free until we have established a system within them, like the system of government in our city, and, by caring for their best part with the best part in us, we install guardians and rulers in them similar to our own, and then proceed to set our children free.” “Yes, that is clear,” said he.

591b

“In which case, Glaucon, how, and based upon what argument, can we maintain that acting unjustly or without restraint or doing something shameful is of benefit to anyone when he will actually be a worse person as a result, despite having a bit more money and power?” “We cannot maintain this at all,” said he. “And is acting unjustly, escaping detection and avoiding punishment beneficial in any way? Or does not someone who escapes detection become even more degenerate, while in the case of someone who does not escape and is punished, his brutish part is made calm and gentle and his gentle part is set free. His entire soul is restored to its very best state and attains a more honourable condition because it has acquired sound-mindedness and justice, accompanied by understanding. Indeed, to the extent that soul is more honourable than body, soul attains a more honourable condition than a body that has acquired strength and beauty along with health.” “Entirely so,” said he.

591c

“Now, will not any intelligent person live his life with all his resources directed to this end, respecting, first and foremost, the branches of learning that will make his soul like this and showing no respect for any others?” “Of course,” said he.

591d

"Then," said I, "he does not give over the condition of his body, or its nurture, to brutish, irrational pleasure, and turn his life in that direction, nor does he look to its health or attach importance to being strong or healthy or beautiful unless he is going to become sound-minded as a result. Rather, he is always to be found attuning the harmony of his body for the sake of the concord of his soul." "Yes, entirely so," said he, "if he is going to be a musician, in truth."

591e

"And," said I, "will he not also bring this order and concord to his acquisition of wealth? He will not increase the sheer size of his fortune beyond all bounds, and his troubles too, because he is in the thrall of popular views on what he should be grateful for." "No, I do not think he would," said he. "Rather," said I, "he will add to or expend his wealth while looking to and guarding the city within himself to the best of his ability. He steers his course in this way in case anything might disturb the elements within him through excess or deficiency of wealth." "Yes, exactly," said he.

592a

"And when it comes to honours, looking to the same principle, he will willingly partake of and taste those that, in his view, will make him better, but he will flee from private or public honours that undo the proper order." "In that case," said he, "if this is his concern, he will not wish to engage in civic affairs." "By the dog, he will," said I, "in the city within himself, very much so, but probably not in his own fatherland, unless some divine good fortune intervenes." "I understand," said he, "you are referring to the city we have now described and are founding, the one that is laid out in words, since I do not think it exists anywhere on earth."

592b

"But perhaps a pattern is laid up in heaven," said I, "for anyone who wishes to behold it and to found himself based on what he

sees. And it makes no difference whether it exists somewhere or will ever exist, for he would engage in the affairs of that city alone and of no other.” “Quite likely,” said he.

BOOK X

595a

”Yes, indeed,” said I, “I have all sorts of ideas in mind as to why our city has been founded in the best possible way. I say this particularly when I reflect upon poetry.” “What aspect?” he asked.

595b

“Our refusal to admit any poetry that employs imitation. Indeed, now that the various parts of the soul have each been distinguished, it is even more evident, in my opinion, that this should not be admitted.” “What do you mean?” “Well, between ourselves, since you won’t denounce me to the tragic poets and all the other imitators, everything of this sort seems to be a mutilation of the minds of those who hear it without possessing the antidote of knowing things as they actually are.” “What exactly do you have in mind when you say this?” he asked.

595c

“This must be spoken,” I replied, “even though the love and reverence that I have for Homer since my childhood prevents me from speaking. Indeed, he seems to have been the first teacher of all the beauties that tragedy possesses, and the leader too. But no man is to be honoured before the truth, so, as I say, this must be spoken.” “Yes, certainly,” said he. “Then listen, or, more to the point, answer my questions.” “Just ask.” “Can you tell me, in general, what precisely imitation is? For I myself do not fully understand what it wants to be.” “And do you think I shall somehow understand it?” said he.

596a

“That would be nothing strange,” said I, “since those with poorer eyesight often see things before those whose vision is sharper.” “That is so,” said he, “but in your presence, I wouldn’t be at all eager to say what it is like, even if something did occur to me. So look for yourself.” “Would you like us to begin then by considering this by our familiar method? For we are presumably accustomed to proposing some one particular form, related to each of the various multiplicities to which we apply the same name. Do you understand?” “I understand.” “Then, let’s propose this now for any of the multiplicities that you want, beds and tables for example, if you like. There are, presumably, many of these.” “Of course.”

596b

“But there are, I presume, two forms related to these items, one form of bed and one form of table.” “Yes.” “Aren’t we also accustomed to saying that the artificer producing either of the items is looking towards the form, and in this way he makes the beds and tables that we use, and the same applies 596c to other items? Indeed, none of the craftsmen, I presume, produces the form itself.” “How could he?” “Not at all, but let’s see what you call the artificer in the following case.” “What artificer?” “The one who makes everything that each particular craftsman makes.” “You are speaking of a clever and most amazing man.” “I’m not finished yet. You’ll soon say so all the more, for this same craftsman is not only able to make all manufactured items, but he also makes everything that springs from the earth, and he fashions all the living creatures, and everything else too, and himself, and, in addition to these, earth, heaven and gods, and he fashions everything that’s in heaven and in Hades under the earth.” “You are speaking,” said he, “of an absolutely amazing sophist.” “Don’t you believe me?” I asked. “Well, tell me, do you think that an artificer like this doesn’t exist at all, or do you think that there could, in a way, be a maker of all these things, although in another way there could not? Or are you not aware

that even you, yourself, would be able to make all these in a way?" "And what," he asked, "is this 'way'?"

596d

"It's not difficult," said I. "This crafting is done quickly in many ways, but it is surely quickest if you are prepared to take a mirror and carry it around wherever you go. Then you will quickly make a sun and whatever is in the sky, you will quickly make earth, quickly make yourself and the other creatures too, manufactured items, plants, and whatever else was mentioned just now." "Yes," said he, "they are appearances that do not, I take it, exist in truth."

596e

"Excellent," said I, "that's just what the argument needs. For a painter, I believe, is an artificer of this sort. Is this so?" "Of course." "But you will maintain, I imagine, that what he makes is not true. And yet, the painter does in a way make a bed, does he not?" "Yes," said he, "he too makes an appearance of a bed anyway." "What about the bed-maker? Didn't we say earlier that he does not make the form, which, according to us, is what bed is? He makes some particular bed." "Yes, so we said." "Now, isn't it the case that if he does not make what it is, he would not be making what is, would he? Although, something of this sort is like what is, but is not what is. So, if someone were to maintain that what the work of the artificer of the bed, or of any other artificer produces, 'is' in the most complete sense, he is unlikely to be speaking the truth."

597a

"Yes," said he, "at least that would be the opinion of those who spend their time on arguments of this sort." "Then, we should not be at all surprised if the manufactured bed also proves to be somewhat obscure in comparison with truth." "Indeed not." "So," said I, "would you like us to use these particular examples to enquire into what precisely this imitator is?" "As you wish," said he. "It turns out then that there are these three beds, first

is the one that is in nature, which we would maintain, I believe, was produced by God, or is there someone else?" "No one else, in my view." "Then there is the one that the carpenter produced." "Yes," said he. "And the one the painter produced. Is this so?"

597b

"So be it." "Then, the painter, the bed-maker and God, these three are responsible for three forms of bed." "Yes, three."

597c

"Now, God made only one bed, itself, what bed is, either because he did not want to make more or because some necessity was laid upon him to fashion just one bed in nature. Two or more beds of this sort were not planted by God, nor will they ever grow naturally." "Why is that?" he asked. "Because," said I, "if he were to make only two, another one would make its appearance, whose form both those others would possess, and that third bed, and not the other two, would be 'what bed is'." "Correct," said he.

597d

"So God, knowing all this, I imagine, made it one by nature because he wanted actually to be a maker of a bed that actually is, and not a maker of some particular bed, or another mere bed-maker." "Quite likely." "Now, do you want us to refer to him as its natural maker or something of that sort?" "That's the right name," said he, "especially since he has made this and everything else, through nature." "What about the carpenter? Won't we call him the artificer of a bed?" "Yes." "And shall we refer to the painter as an artificer and maker of this sort of thing?" "Not at all." "Then, what shall we say he is in relation to the bed?"

597e

"I think," said he, "that it is most reasonable to refer to him as an imitator of whatever those others are artificers of." "So be it," said I. "Are you to call the person whose product is at a third

remove from nature, an imitator?” “Yes, certainly,” said he. “So this will include the maker of tragedies if he is indeed an imitator. He is naturally at some third remove from the king and from the truth, as are all the other imitators.” “Quite likely.”

598a

“We have agreed then about the imitator. But tell me something about the painter. Does he attempt to imitate the thing itself, the thing in nature in each case, or does he imitate the works of the artificers?” “The works of the artificers,” said he. “As they are or as they appear? You still have to make this distinction.” “How do you mean?” he asked. “As follows. If you look at a bed from the side or from the front, or in any other way, does it differ from what it, itself, is? Or does it not differ at all even though it appears different, and does the same hold for everything else too?” “That’s it,” said he, “it appears different but doesn’t differ at all.”

598b

“Then, consider this very issue. What is painting directed towards in each case? Is it directed towards imitating what is as it is, or towards imitating what appears as it appears? Is it an imitation of an appearance or of truth?” “Of an appearance,” said he. “So, imitation is surely at a far remove from the truth, and it seems it can fashion everything because it gets hold of some small part of each, and this is an image. For instance, our painter, we ^{598c} say, will paint a cobbler for us, or a carpenter or any other artificer, without knowing anything about any of their skills. But nevertheless, if the painter were a good one and he painted a carpenter ^{598d} and showed it from afar to children, or men devoid of intelligence, he would deceive them into thinking that it was, in truth, a carpenter.” “Of course.” “And in general, my friend, there is, in my view, something we should keep in mind in relation to everything of this sort. If someone ever tells us that he has met a person who is knowledgeable

about craftsmanship of every sort and who knows whatever anyone else knows with greater precision than anyone else, we should reply to someone like this that he is a simple-minded fellow who has, it seems, met up with a beguiler and an imitator, and has been deceived into thinking that the man is wise beyond all measure because he himself is unable to test knowledge, lack of knowledge, and imitation.” “Very true,” said he.

598e

“So, after this,” said I, “mustn’t we consider tragic poetry and its leader, Homer, since we hear from some people that these poets know everything, all skills, all human affairs relating to excellence and vice, and, indeed, all matters divine? For they say that it is necessary for the good poet to compose whilst possessed of knowledge, if he is going to compose well on whatever he is writing about, or else be unable to compose at all. We need to consider carefully then whether these people have met with imitators of this sort and have been deceived. Are they looking at the products of imitators without being aware that these are at a third remove from what is, and are easy to make without knowing the truth, because they are producing appearances, not things that are? Or do they actually have a point? Do the good poets really have knowledge of these subjects when they impress so many people with their eloquence?”

599a

“This certainly must be tested,” said he. “Now, do you think that if someone were able to make both the original and the image, he would devote himself seriously to crafting images and make this the primary concern of his own life, his most prized possession?” “I do not.”

599b

“But, I imagine, if he were knowledgeable, in truth, about the objects he is imitating, he would much prefer to engage

seriously with real work rather than making imitations. He would endeavour to leave behind various beautiful works of his own as memorials, and he would be more eager to receive praise than to give praise.” “I think so,” said he, “since the honour and the advantage are not equal.”

599c

“Well, we shall not demand an account from Homer or any of the other poets on other subjects by asking them if any of them was ever a medical expert rather than a mere imitator of medical terminology; whether any poet, ancient or modern, is said to have made someone healthy, just as Asclepius did,¹¹⁴ or what students of medicine they have left behind in the way that Asclepius left successors. Nor indeed should we ask them about any other skill. No, we should leave all that.

599d

But when it comes to the most important and sublime matters about which Homer attempts to speak, such as warfare, military strategy, the governing of cities and the education of the person, it is only right, I believe, to question him and ask, ‘Dear Homer, if you are not actually at a third remove from the truth about excellence, a mere craftsman of an image, someone we defined as an imitator, but if you are indeed at a second remove and would be able to recognise what sorts of activities make people better or worse personally and as citizens, then tell us which cities have been better governed because of you, as Sparta was because of Lycurgus?¹¹⁵ And lots of other cities too, some large, some small, were they better governed because of numerous others? What city celebrates you for being a good lawgiver and for being of service to them? Italy and Sicily celebrate ^{599e} Charondas,¹¹⁶ we celebrate Solon,¹¹⁷ but who celebrates you?’ Will he have anything to say?” “I do not think so,” said Glaucon. “At any rate, even the Homeric band¹¹⁸ themselves have nothing to say on the matter.”

600a

“And, indeed, was any war in Homer’s time said to have been well conducted under the command or advice of the man himself? Does anyone remember one?” “Not a one.” “Well then, what about the works of a wise man, the insights and innovations into human skills and activities in general, the sort that Thales the Milesian or Anacharsis the Scythian introduced?¹¹⁹ Are there reports of this sort of thing?” “Not at all, nothing of this sort.”

600b

“In that case, if this did not happen in the civic realm, in private was Homer himself, during his lifetime, said to have taken on a role as leader of their education, for some people? Did they then love being with him so much that they passed on a certain Homeric way of life to those who came after them? Was he, therefore, like Pythagoras, who was loved for this very reason and whose followers even now refer to their manner of life as Pythagorean, and seem somehow to stand out from everyone else?”

600c

“No,” said he, “nothing like this is reported either. Indeed, Socrates, perhaps Homer’s disciple, Creophylos,¹²⁰ would prove to be more ridiculous for his education than for his name if all that is said about Homer is true, since it is reported that Homer, even during his own lifetime, was largely ignored by this fellow.” “Yes,” said I, “that is what is reported. But, Glaucon, if Homer really had been able to educate people and make them better, because he had the ability not just to imitate but to understand the matters in question, don’t you think he would have produced large numbers of disciples and been honoured and loved by them? While Protagoras of Abdera and Prodicus of Ceos,¹²¹ and very many ^{600d} others, are able to convince their contemporaries in private conversations that they will not be able to manage their own household or city unless they entrust their education to them. And in return for this wisdom, their

disciples love them so much that they are just about ready to carry them around, head high. Yet, are we to say that although he really was able to help them towards excellence, the people of his own time allowed Homer, and Hesiod too, to travel about reciting poems ^{600e} and did not hold them close, more closely than gold, and compel these poets to dwell with them in their homes? And if they did not persuade them, wouldn't they themselves have escorted them wherever they went until they had received an adequate education?" "I think, Socrates," said he, "that what you are saying is absolutely true." "So, should we propose that all poetic types, beginning with Homer, are imitators of images of excellence, and of anything else they write poems about, but they have no contact with the truth? Aren't they rather, as we said just now, like the painter, who, without knowing anything about cob- ^{601a} bling himself, will produce what seems to be a cobbler to those who also know nothing about this and merely look at the colours and shapes?" "Yes, certainly." "In this way then, I imagine we shall maintain that the poetic type too applies certain colours to the various skills with his words and phrases, even though he himself knows nothing except how to imitate. As a result, other people like himself, who only look at the words, think he is speaking extremely well, whether he is speaking with metre, rhythm and harmony about cob- ^{601b} bling, or about military strategy, or about anything else at all, so great is the natural enchantment that these three possess. But when these poetic productions are stripped of their musical colouration and are spoken unadorned, I think you know the show they put on, since I presume you have seen this yourself." "I have," said he.

^{601c}

"Are they not," said I, "like the faces of youths who are in their prime, but not beautiful when their bloom of youth is gone?" "Absolutely," said he. "Come on then, consider this carefully. The maker of the image, the imitator, according to us knows

nothing of what is, but does know what appears. Isn't this so?" "Yes." "Well, we shouldn't leave this half-said; we should look at it properly." "Speak on," said he. "Don't we say that the painter paints the reins and the bit in the mouth of a horse?" "Yes." "But the leatherworker and the blacksmith will make them." "Indeed." "Now, does the painter know what qualities the reins or the bit should have, or is this unknown even to the smith and the leatherworker who make them? Is it only the person who knows how to use these, the horseman, who knows what qualities they should have?" "Very true."

601d

"Won't we say that this applies in all cases?" "How?" "In each case, are there these three skills – using, making and imitating?" "Yes." "Now, isn't the excellence, beauty and correctness of each manufactured item, living creature or activity related solely to the use for which each has been made, or naturally produced?" "So it is." "So, it is quite necessary that the user be most experienced with the particular item, and that he be the one who reports to the maker the good and bad qualities that it manifests when used by the user. The flautist, for example, presumably reports back to the flute-maker as to which flutes serve his purpose when he plays them, and he instructs him as to how they should be made. Then the flute-maker will serve his need." "Of course."

601e

"So, doesn't one person report back, knowledgeably, about the good and bad qualities of the flutes, while the other believes him and makes them?" "Yes." "So, in relation to the same item, the maker will have a correct belief about its excellence or deficiency by associating with someone who knows, and by being compelled to hear what he has to say. But it is the user who will have knowledge." "Certainly."

602a

“Now, will the imitator, from using them, have knowledge of whether or not the things he paints are good and right, or will he have right opinion because he is required to associate with the person who knows, and be instructed as to how he is to paint them?” “Neither.” “So the imitator will neither know, nor have right opinion, concerning what’s beautiful or bad about whatever he is imitating.” “It seems not.” “The poetic imitator would have a charming relationship with the wisdom of whoever he writes about.” “Not really.”

602b

“But he will proceed to imitate nevertheless, without knowing how the object in question may be good or bad. It seems, rather, that he will imitate the sort of thing that seems beautiful to most people, people who don’t know anything about it.” “What else can he do?” “Well then, it looks as if all this has been reasonably well agreed between us: the imitator knows nothing worth mentioning about the things he imitates; the imitation is a mere plaything devoid of seriousness; and those who are involved in tragic poetry, whether in iambic or epic metre, are all imitators, through and through.” “Yes, certainly.”

602c

“By Zeus,” said I, “this business of imitation is concerned with something at a third remove from the truth. Isn’t it so?” “Yes.” “And what aspect of the person does it have the power to influence?” “What sort of aspect are you referring to?” “As follows. The same magnitude seen from near and then from afar does not appear equal to us.” “It does not.”

602d

“And the same objects appear bent or straight when they are viewed in or out of water; concave or convex objects look flat to our eyes because of the play of colours, and all such confusion is obviously itself present in us, in the soul. And shadow-drawing, taking advantage of this tendency in our nature, is nothing short of sorcery, and so too are conjuring and many other

clever contrivances of this sort.” “True.” “Now, weren’t measuring, counting and weighing invented as intelligent safeguards against all this so that we might not be dominated by what appears greater or less, or more or heavier, but by that which has been calculated, measured or, indeed, weighed?” “Of course.”

602e

“But this function would belong to the calculating part of the soul.” “Yes, it belongs to this part.” “But when this part has done its measuring and has indicated that some objects are greater than or less than or equal to others, the contrary qualities often present themselves at the same time in relation to the very same objects.” “Yes.” “Now, didn’t we say that it is impossible for the same thing to hold contrary views about the same thing at the same time?” “And we were right to say so.”

603a

“So, the part of the soul that is forming opinions contrary to the measurements would not be the same as the part that does so on the basis of the measurements.” “No, it would not.” “But the part that trusts in measurement and calculation would be the best part of the soul.” “Indeed.” “So, the part that is opposed to this would be one of the lesser elements in us.” “Necessarily.”

603b

“Well, this is what I wanted us to agree upon when I was saying that painting and imitation generally fashion a product that is far removed from the truth. And the part in us that it consorts with is, in turn, far removed from intelligence, and imitation is its companion and friend for no sound or true purpose.” “Entirely so,” said he. “So, imitation, which is something lowly, generates lowly offspring by associating with something lowly.” “So it seems.” “Does that,” said I, “apply only to imitation we can see, or does it also apply to that which we can hear, the imitation we call poetry?” “It is likely,” said he, “to apply to poetry too.”

603c

“Well,” said I, “let’s not put our trust only in what’s likely by analogy with painting. Let’s take a look, rather, at the very part of the mind with which poetic imitation consorts, and see whether it is lowly or superior.” “Yes, that’s what’s needed.” “Then let’s propose the following. Imitation, we say, imitates human beings performing actions under compulsion or voluntarily, thinking that they have done well or done badly as a result of the activity and experiencing pain, or being delighted in all these. Is there anything more to it than this?” “Nothing.”

603d

“Now, is the person in a unified state of mind in all of these cases? Or is there faction, just as there was in the case of seeing, when he held opposite opinions within himself about the same objects at the same time? Is it the same in the case of these activities; is there faction and does he fight with himself? But I recall that there is no longer any need for us to agree on this issue. Indeed, we agreed all of this quite adequately in the previous arguments; our souls are teeming with countless contradictions of this sort, arising at the same time.” “Correct,” said he. “Correct, indeed,” said I, “but I think we now need to recount in detail something we omitted at the time.” “What is it?” he asked.

603e

“We also said earlier, I believe, that when a reasonable man meets with a misfortune, such as the loss of a son or something that is very important to him, he will bear this loss more easily than other people.” “Entirely so.” “But now let’s consider whether he will experience no distress, or, this being impossible, he will somehow keep measure in relation to the pain.” “More the latter,” said he, “that’s the truth.” “Now, tell me this about him. Do you think he will struggle more against the pain, and resist it, when he can be seen by his fellows or when he is alone just by himself?” “Presumably,” said he, “he

will fight it much more when he is seen by others.”

604a

“But when he is on his own, I imagine, he will dare to utter lots of things which he would be ashamed of if anyone were to hear him. He will also do lots of things which he would not allow anyone to see him doing.” “So he would,” said he. “Don’t reason and law exhort him to resist, while the feeling itself draws him to the pain?” “True.”

604b

“But when a contrary tendency arises in a person about the same thing, at the same time, we maintain that the person must have two elements within him.” “Of course.” “Isn’t one of them ready to obey the law and follow its guidance?” “How?”

604c

“The law declares, I presume, that the very best course of action is to be at peace in the face of misfortunes, and not be distressed, because the good or bad of such situations is not obvious. There is no future advantage in taking things badly; nothing in human affairs deserves to be taken seriously, and being pained acts as an impediment to the very thing whose assistance we need as quickly as possible in these cases.” “What,” said he, “are you referring to?” “To deliberation,” said I, “about what has happened and to arranging one’s own affairs in the way that reason deems best, as if responding to the fall of the dice, without wasting time like children who have had a fall, crying and holding on to the hurt. We should continually accustom the soul to turn as quickly as possible to the process of healing and to ensuring that whatever has fallen or ^{604d} become diseased is put right, banishing lamentation by means of the healing art.” “This,” he said, “is certainly the right way for someone to deal with life’s misfortunes.” “So, according to us, our very best part is prepared to follow this reasoning?” “Of course.” “But the part that leads us back towards our memories of what happened and to our lamentations about it, and has an

insatiable desire for these, is irrational and idle and a friend of cowardice. Isn't this what we shall say?" "We shall indeed."

604e

"Now, one of these, the troubled one, is highly susceptible to imitation in all sorts of ways, while the intelligent peaceful disposition, because it is always much the same as itself, is neither easy to imitate nor, when it is imitated, is it easily understood, especially not by a large crowd of people of all sorts gathered together in a theatre. For the imitation is of an experience that is somehow alien to them."

605a

"Entirely so." "Then, it is obvious that the imitative poet has no natural affinity with the good part of the soul, and his wisdom is not designed to please this if he is going to be well regarded among the general population. He has, rather, an affinity with the troubled and complex character because it is so easy to imitate." "Obviously."

605b

"Isn't it only right that we set him aside at this stage and put him with the painter as his counterpart? In fact, he resembles him by producing products that are inferior in terms of their truth. But he is similar to him too in appealing to that other part of the soul rather than to the best part. Accordingly, we would already be justified in denying him admission into a city that is to be well regulated, because he rouses this part of the soul and nurtures it, and by making it strong he destroys the rational part. It's as if, in the case of a city, someone were to put degenerate people in charge, entrust the city to them, and destroy the better sort. Shall we maintain that the imitative poet does the same by establishing an evil form of government privately in the soul of each individual, grat- 605c ifying the irrational part that cannot even distinguish what's large from what's small, and believes that the same things are now big, now little? Is he not a maker of images, images that are very far

removed from the truth?" "Entirely so." "But we have not yet brought our significant accusations against poetry. For its ability to do harm, even to people of the best sort, with very few exceptions, is terrible in the extreme." "Inevitably, if it actually does this." "Listen and consider. Indeed, even the best of us, I presume, has had the experience of listening ^{605d} to Homer or one of the other tragic poets, imitating one of the heroes, grief-stricken, delivering a speech that stretches out into lengthy lamentations, or even singing and beating his breast. You know that we are delighted, we surrender ourselves, we follow along and feel what they feel, and in all seriousness we praise whoever is best able to give us such an experience and call him a good poet." "I know, of course."

^{605e}

"But when some personal misfortune befalls any of us, you realise, in this case, that we pride ourselves on the opposite response, on being able to remain at peace and to endure it, since this is the response of a man, while the other, the one we just praised, is a woman's response." "I realise this," said he. "Now," said I, "is there anything good about this praise? When someone sees a man like this, a man he himself would be ashamed to be like and would not accept, should he be delighted and praise him rather than being filled with loathing?" "No, by Zeus," said he, "that does not seem reasonable."

^{606a}

"Yes," said I, "especially if you were to consider it in this way." "In what way?" "Well, if you were to consider that the poets now satisfy and gratify the part that is restrained by force when dealing with private misfortunes and which hungers for its proper fill of crying and lamenting and has a natural desire for these. But the best part of us, by nature, has not been sufficiently educated by reason and habit, so it relaxes its guardianship of this mournful part since the man is looking at the suffering of other people, and he himself feels no shame if

someone else claims to be good, but engages in inappropriate lamentation. So he praises and pities this person, thinking there is advantage in that. It is a pleasure he will not be deprived of by despising the whole poem. Indeed, in my view, there are few who are capable of working out that whatever enjoyment we derive from the affairs of others necessarily affects our own. For having indulged pity to the full with the misfortunes of others, it is not easy to restrain it in the face of our own."

606b

"Very true," said he. "Now, doesn't the same argument apply to laughter? If you are absolutely delighted when jokes you would be ashamed to make yourself are acted out on the comic stage, or heard in private, and you don't detest them for their baseness, aren't you doing exactly what we described in the case of pity? For something within you wanted to make a joke and you restrained it then for fear of seeming like a clown. But now you are letting it loose, and having allowed it free rein you will frequently give in to this, unwittingly, in private, and so become a comic poet yourself." "Very much so," said he.

606c

"And poetic imitation affects us in various ways in the case of sexual desires, anger, and all the appetites, pleasures and pains of the soul, which, we maintain, accompany every action of ours. It actually nurtures these and waters them when they should be left to wither, and sets them up as rulers when they should be under authority, so that we may become better and happier rather than worse and more wretched." "I cannot disagree," said he.

606d

"In that case, Glaucon," said I, "whenever you come across Homer's eulogists declaring that this poet has educated Greece, that he deserves to be adopted and studied both for the management and for the education of human affairs, and that everyone should live his own life under the arrangements

suggested by this poet, you should embrace them and love them for doing their very best, and concede that Homer is highly poetic and our foremost tragic poet. But you must understand that the only poetry we can admit into our city are hymns to the gods and praises of good people.

606e

And if you admit the voluptuous Muse, in lyric or epic form, pleasure and pain will be kings of your city instead of law and the reasoning that always seems best to the community.”

607a

“Very true,” said he. “Well,” said I, “now that we have revisited the question of poetry, let this be our defence. We were, after all, acting reasonably when we banished it from our city, since this is what it is like. The argument proved this to us. But in case poetry accuses us of a certain harshness and lack of refinement, let’s explain to it that a dispute between philosophy and poetry is of ancient date. Indeed, there are signs of this long-standing opposition in expressions such as, ‘the yelping hound that ^{607b} bays against her master’, and ‘paramount in the empty talk of fools’, and ‘the mob that rules the over-wise’, and ‘the subtle thinkers who turn out to be poor’, and there are scores of others. Nevertheless, let’s declare that if someone is able to put forward an argument as to why there should be poetry and imitation, whose aim is pleasure, in a well-regulated city, we would gladly receive these back again because we realise that we are still charmed by them. But it is an unholy act to betray what you think to be true. Is this so, my friend? Aren’t you charmed by poetry too, especially when you meet it through Homer?” “Very much so.”

607c

“Then, isn’t it only right that we allow poetry back under these circumstances, once it has defended itself in lyric or in some other metre?” “Yes, entirely so.”

607d

“And we would, presumably, also allow its supporters who are not poetical but who do love poetry to make a case on its behalf, devoid of poetic metre, arguing that it is not only a source of ^{607e} pleasure to civic society and to human life, but a source of benefit too. And we would listen fairly, since we would surely gain an advantage if poetry proved to be beneficial rather than merely pleasant.” “Yes,” said he, “the advantage would inevitably be ours.” “But if not, my dear friend, we must act like those who have fallen in love with someone but forcibly restrain themselves, nevertheless, because they believe that the love is not beneficial. Because of ^{608a} the love of such poetry, engendered by our upbringing under our good systems of government, we shall be well disposed to a proof that it is utterly good and true. But as long as it is unable to offer a defence, we shall listen to it while chanting this argument to ourselves, the one we are stating, this charm of ours, as a precaution against falling once more into the childish love that most people have for such poetry. But we are now aware that it must not be taken seriously, as something serious ^{608b} that lays hold of the truth. Rather, whoever hears poetry should be careful about it, out of fear for the city within himself, and should heed whatever we have said about poetry.” “I agree entirely,” said he. “Yes, dear Glaucon,” said I, “the struggle is a great one, greater than you think. What’s at stake is becoming good or bad, and so we should not neglect justice, and excellence in general, because we are excited by honour, money, or any power whatsoever, or indeed by poetry.”

^{608c}

“I agree with you,” said he, “on the basis of all we have recounted, and I think anyone else would agree too.” “And yet,” said I, “we have not recounted the greatest rewards of excellence, and the prizes that are on offer.” “You are referring to something great beyond measure,” said he, “if it is greater than what we have spoken of.” “Could anything great happen in

a short period of time?" I asked. "Indeed, the entire span of time, from childhood to old age, would presumably be short in comparison with all time." "Nothing," said he. "Well then, do you think something immortal should take a short time span like this seriously, but not be serious about all time?"

608d

"I think it should be serious about all time," said he, "but why are you saying this?"

608e

"Are you not aware", said I, "that our soul is immortal and is never destroyed?" And he looked at me, in amazement, and said, "By Zeus, I am not, but are you able to say this?" "I can," said I, "and I think you can too. It's not difficult." "It is for me," said he, "but as it's so easy for you, I would like to hear about it from you." "Hear you shall," said I. "Speak on," said he. "Is there something you call good," I asked, "and something you call bad?" "There is." "Now, do you think about them as I do?" "In what way?" "That which destroys and corrupts everything is what's bad, while that which preserves and confers benefit is what's good." "This is what I think, at any rate," said he.

609a

"What about this? Do you say that there is some particular good or bad that belongs to each individual thing, just as ophthalmia belongs to the eyes, disease to the entire body, mildew to grain, rot to wood, and rust to bronze and iron? I mean, in almost all cases, do you say that there is some badness or disease that belongs to each?" "I do," said he. "Isn't it the case that whenever any of these gets attached to something, it makes whatever it is attached to degenerate, and in the end breaks it down completely and destroys it?" "It must be so."

609b

"So, the bad and the degeneracy that naturally belong to each, destroys each, or if these do not destroy it, there is nothing else that could still corrupt it. For the good will never destroy

anything, nor indeed will that which is neither good nor bad.” “No, how could it?” said he. “So, if we find anything at all which has a specific badness that makes it worse but is unable to dissolve and destroy it, won’t we know at this stage that no destruction belongs to something of such a nature?” “Quite likely,” said he.

609c

“Well then,” said I, “does soul have something particular that makes it bad?” “Very much so,” said he, “everything we were listing just now – injustice, lack of restraint, cowardice and ignorance.” “Now, do any of these dissolve and destroy the soul? And consider carefully in case we are misled into thinking that the unjust and unreasonable person, when caught in his unjust act, is destroyed by that very injustice, even though it is a degeneracy of the soul. Think of it, rather, in the following way. Just as disease, the vice of the body, wastes it away, dissolves it, and brings it to a stage where it is no longer a body, so too, in all the cases we just mentioned, when their own particular badness attaches itself to them or is present in them, they are corrupted by this and eventually cease to exist. Isn’t this so?” “Yes.”

609d

“Come on then, and consider soul in the same manner. Do injustice and vice in general, when present in the soul, corrupt and waste it away by their presence and by attaching to it until they bring the soul to death and separate it from the body.” “No,” said he, “this does not happen at all.” “But it is also unreasonable,” said I, “that something could be destroyed by the degeneracy of another, but not by its own.” “Unreasonable.”

609e

“Yes, Glaucon,” said I, “think about it. We do not think that a body could be destroyed by the degeneracy that belongs to foods themselves, be it staleness, rottenness or anything else. But once the degeneracy of the foods themselves produces a poor condition of the body, in the body, we shall maintain that

because of the foods, it has been destroyed by its own badness, namely, ^{610a} disease. But since the foods are one thing and the body is another, we should never expect the body to be corrupted by their alien badness unless their degeneracy produces its own degeneracy in the body.” “Quite right,” said he. “Well, by the same argument,” said I, “unless degeneracy of the body produces degeneracy of soul, in the soul, we would not expect soul to be destroyed by the alien badness of the body, a badness that belongs to something else, in the absence of soul’s own particular degeneracy.” “Indeed,” said he, “that is reasonable.”

^{610b}

“Well, we should either refute these assertions because we were wrong, or, as long as they stand unrefuted, we should not declare that the soul is ever destroyed in any sense by fever or any other disease, by slaughter, or even if someone chops the body up into tiny pieces, until someone proves that soul itself becomes more unjust, or more unholy because these things happen to the body. We ^{610c} should not allow anyone to maintain that soul or anything else is destroyed when an alien badness arises in it, in the absence of its own particular badness.” “But you may be sure,” said he, “that no one will ever prove that the souls of those who are dying become more unjust because of death.” “But,” said I, “suppose someone is bold enough to attack this argument so that he will not be forced to accept that souls are immortal. If he says that the dying person does become more degenerate and more unjust, we shall, presumably, maintain that if this is true, then injustice is fatal to its possessor, just as fatal as disease. So by its own nature it would kill those who catch it, killing those ^{610d} who have more of it quite quickly, and those who have less of it more gradually. This would be unlike the present situation where the unjust die because of their injustice, but at the hands of others who are imposing a penalty upon them.” “By Zeus,” said he, “if injustice

is going to be fatal to its possessor, it will turn out not to be so terrible after all, for it would be a release from evils. But I think it is more likely to ^{610e} turn out to be the exact opposite. It kills others, if that is actually possible, while making its possessor more lively, and in addition to being more lively, more awake too. And so, in my view, it seems nowhere near to being fatal.” “You are right,” said I. “In fact, when its own particular degeneracy and its own particular badness is not sufficient to kill or destroy soul, then badness assigned to the destruction of something else will hardly destroy soul, or anything else for that matter, except that which it is assigned to destroy.” “Hardly likely, indeed,” said he.

^{611a}

“In that case, since it is not destroyed by any badness, either its own or an alien one, it obviously must be something that always is, and since it always is, mustn’t it be immortal?” “It must,” said he. “Well,” said I, “this is how matters stand, and since this is so, you may note that the souls must always be the same. For their number could not become less, I presume, since none are destroyed, nor could there be more of them since you know that any increase in number among any immortal things would come from the mortal, and everything would, in the end, be immortal.” “True.”

^{611b}

“But,” said I, “let us not think that this is so, for the argument will not allow it. Nor again, should we think that soul, in its truest nature, is the sort of thing that is itself full of variation, dissimilarity and divergence, with respect to itself.” “How do you mean?” he asked. “It is not easy,” said I, “for something to be everlasting when it is composed of many things and they have not been put together in the best possible way, which is how the soul appeared to us just now.” “No, that is not likely to be easy.”

^{611c}

“Well, although our earlier argument, and others, would compel us to accept that soul is immortal, we should still behold what it is like in truth, not mutilated by its association with the body and other bad influences, which is how we behold it now. We should, rather, use reason to see it properly, as it is when it has been purified, and we shall find that it is much more beautiful, and we shall discern justice and injustice with greater clarity, and everything else we have just described. We have now spoken the truth about it, as it appears at the moment. But although we behold it in this condition, we are like people looking at the sea god, Glaucus, who are still unable, easily, to ^{611d} see his ancient nature because the original parts of his body have been broken off, smashed and mutilated by the waves. And other things have attached themselves to him, such as shells and seaweed and rocks, so that he seems more like some wild animal rather than what he is by nature. That’s also how we behold the soul, in a condition that results from countless bad influences. But, dear Glaucon, we should look elsewhere.” “Where?” said he.

^{611e}

“We should look to soul’s love of wisdom and consider what it is in contact with, and the sort of thing it strives to associate with, because it is akin to the divine, the immortal, and what always is. We should consider what it would become like by directing itself entirely to this sort of thing, when it has lifted itself by this effort out of the sea that it now resides in and has knocked off the stones and shells that now encrust it, since it is feasting on earth and is surrounded by a wild profusion of earth and stone, because of the feasting that is generally called happiness. Then one would see soul’s true nature, what it is like, and how it is so, and whether its form is multiple or just one. But we have now described what happens to it, and the forms it takes in human life, in what I regard as a satisfactory manner.” “Entirely so,” said he.

612a

"In that case," said I, "did we not do away with the other criticisms in the course of our argument without praising the rewards and good reputation that are associated with justice, as you say Hesiod and Homer do? Have we not found that justice itself is best for soul itself, and that soul should perform just actions whether it possesses the ring of Gyges or not, and the helmet of Hades too, in addition to that famous ring?"¹²² "Very true," said he.

612b

"Well then, Glaucon," said I, "at this stage there should, in addition, be no reluctance about restoring to justice, and to excellence in general, any rewards of any kind that they afford to the soul, either from humanity or from the gods, during a person's life or after he dies." "Absolutely," said he. "In that case, will you restore to me what you borrowed in the argument?" "What precisely?"

612c

"I conceded to you that the just man might be reputed unjust, and the unjust man might be reputed just. You made this request, and even if these cannot go unnoticed by gods and mankind, the concession had to be made nevertheless for the sake of the argument, so that justice itself might be judged alongside injustice itself. Don't you remember?" "It would be an injustice on my part," said he, "if I did not."

612d

"Well," said I, "now that they have been judged, I demand, on behalf of justice, that you restore ^{612e} its good reputation among gods and men, and that we too should concur that it is held in such high repute so that justice may carry off the victory prizes that come from being reputed to possess justice, prizes it bestows upon those who possess it in truth. Indeed, justice has already proved that it bestows the goods that come from actually being just, and is not deceiving those who really do

attain to it.” “A just demand,” said he. “Would you concede, firstly,” said I, “that the gods certainly are not unaware of what these two, justice and injustice, are like?” “We shall concede that,” said he. “But if there is awareness of both, then one would be loved by the gods and the other hated by the gods, as we agreed at the outset.” “Quite so.”

613a

“And won’t we agree that for the person who is loved by the gods, whatever comes from the gods, at any rate, is all for the best, unless some unavoidable badness accrues to him from a former transgression?” “Certainly.” “So, in the case of the just man, we may presume that whether poverty or disease or one of the so-called evils befalls him, these will end in some good for this man during his lifetime or after his death. For the gods certainly will never neglect someone who has an eager desire to become just ^{613b} and to become as much like unto God as a human being possibly can by pursuing excellence.” “Yes,” said he, “a person like this is hardly likely to be neglected by his like.” “And shouldn’t we presume that the exact opposite of all this applies to the unjust person?” “Very much so.” “These, then, would be the sorts of prizes the gods give to the just man.” “Well, that is what I think anyway,” said he.

613c

“But what prizes,” said I, “does he receive from mankind? If we are to describe the situation as it is, isn’t it somewhat as follows. Don’t the clever but unjust people behave like runners who run well when going up the track, but not in the other direction? At first they sprint away at a brisk pace, but in the end they become laughing stocks as they run off the track without the victory wreath, with their ears drooping down to their shoulders. But the true runners keep going to the very end, collect their prizes, and are crowned as victors. Isn’t this also how things turn out, for the most part, in the case of just people? Towards the end of each undertaking or association, or

their entire life, are they not well regarded, and don't they carry off the prizes that their fellow men bestow?" "Yes, indeed."

613d

"So, will you put up with it if I say the same things about these people as you said about unjust people? For I shall say that when the just people get older, they take up positions of authority in their own city if they wish, they marry from whatever families they wish, and marry their children into any families they please. In fact, I am now saying about these people everything you then said about those people. And furthermore, I shall say that the unjust, in most cases, even if they go undetected when young, are caught at the end of their course and become figures of fun. In old age they are trampled upon like wretches by strangers and by their own people, they are whipped ^{613e} and they suffer everything you rightly described as brutal. I won't repeat the details, so just assume that you have heard me list them and tell me if you will put up with my saying this." "Yes, indeed," said he, "it's only right that you say so."

614a

"These, then," said I, "would be the sorts of prizes, rewards and gifts that the just person receives from gods and his fellow men during his own lifetime, in addition to those goods that justice itself bestows." "Noble and secure rewards, indeed," said he.

614b

"Well, they are nothing," said I, "in number or extent in comparison with those that await the just and the unjust after death. These should now be heard so that each of them may hear in full what they deserve to hear from the argument." "Speak on," said he, "as there are not many things I'd be more pleased to listen to." "I shan't," said I, "tell you the long tale that Alcinous told, but a story of a brave man, Er, the son of Armenius, a Pamphylian by race. "Once upon a time, he met his death on the battlefield, and when the corpses were being gathered after ten days, already decomposing, his body was

found in good condition. He was brought home, and on the twelfth day, as the funeral was about to begin and he was lying on the pyre, he revived, and having come back to life he described what he had seen there, in that other place.

614c

“He said that when his soul went forth, it proceeded along with many others, and they arrived at a mysterious region in which there were two openings in the earth, side by side, and two others in the heaven above, directly opposite them. Judges were seated between these, and once they had passed judgement they ordered the just to proceed upwards to the right, through the heaven, with signs attached in front of them indicating the judgements that had been passed, while they ordered the unjust to proceed downwards to the left, also wearing signs behind them indicating all they had done. But when he himself came forward, they told him that he must be a messenger to humanity to tell of what went on there, and they directed him to listen and to observe everything in the place.

614d

“He said that he saw souls there, departing through one opening in the heaven and one in the earth after judgement had been passed upon them. Through the other two openings, souls came up out of the earth in one case, full of squalor and filth, while from the other opening other souls descended from the heaven, purified. They arrived continually, looking as if they had completed a lengthy journey, and they made their way gladly to the meadow and encamped there, as if at a religious festival. Those who recognised one another embraced, and those who had come out of the earth enquired from the others about what went on there in the other place, while those who had come from the heaven asked about what went on below. They swapped stories with one ^{614e} another, one group wailing and lamenting as they recalled whatever they had suffered and seen, and what it was like on their journey beneath the earth,

which was a journey of a thousand years, while those who had come from the heaven, for their part, described pleasant experiences and scenes beautiful beyond measure.

615a

“To recount the many details, Glaucon, would take a long time, but the summation”, he said, “was as follows. However many wrongs the person had done, to however many people, he paid a just penalty for them all in turn, a tenfold penalty for each, that is, a period of one hundred years in each case, which is the span of a human life, so that the penalty paid would be ten times the unjust act. For instance, if someone had been responsible for many deaths by betraying entire cities or armies and reducing them to slavery, or had been responsible for some other enormity besides, they would receive back the pain of all these multiplied tenfold for each. Then again, if ^{615b} someone had done good deeds and had become just and holy, they would receive their deserved reward on the same basis. And he also made comments, not worth recalling, about those who died as soon as they were born, or lived for but a short time. And he described even greater penalties in cases of disrespect and respect for gods and for parents, and slaying with one’s own hand.

615c

“Now, he said that he was present when one person asked another, ‘Where is Ardiaeus the Great?’ This Ardiaeus had been tyrant of some city in Pamphylia a thousand years before then, and he had murdered his aged father and his elder brother, and was said to have done many other unholy deeds too. Er said that the person who was questioned replied, ‘He has not come here, nor ^{615d} will he ever come here. In fact, this was one of the terrible scenes that we beheld. When we were close to the mouth of the chasm and about to come out after all that we had been through, we suddenly caught sight of him, and others too, most of them surely tyrants, but there were also some ^{615e} private citizens who had committed great crimes. Just when

they thought they were going to go up, the mouth of the chasm did not let them, but it gave a roar whenever someone in such an incurable condition of degeneracy or someone who had not paid the penalty in full tried to come up. Then,' said he, 'wild men of fiery aspect, who had been standing by, recognised the sound, took hold of some of them and led them away. But they bound Ardiaeus and others, hand, foot and ^{616a} head, flung them down and flayed them, dragged them to the side of the road to strip their skin on thorns, indicating to those who kept passing by why they were taking them away and that they were about to throw them into Tartarus.'¹²³ Then, although they had already met with many terrors of all sorts, the man said that this exceeded them all, the fear that this voice might emerge in their case when they went up. And each went through with great delight as the voice was silent.

^{616b}

"Such were the just penalties and punishments that Er described, and the blessings were the counterparts of these. But once seven days had elapsed for each group in the meadow, they had to get up on the eighth day and go on a journey from there. In four days they arrived at a place where they beheld a light extending straight from above, through all heaven and earth, like a pillar bearing a strong resemblance to a rainbow, but brighter and purer. This they arrived at after a ^{616c} further day's travel, and there, at the light's centre, they saw the extremities of its bonds extending from the heaven, for this light is what binds the heaven together, like the braces under a trireme, holding the entire revolution of the heaven together in this way. The spindle of Necessity, by which all the heavenly revolutions are turned, was extending from the extremities. Its shaft and its hook were made of adamant, and its whorl from a mixture of this and of other materials.

^{616d}

“The nature of the whorl was as follows. Although its shape was like what we have here – you should recognise what it was like from what he said – it was as if one large whorl, hollow and scooped out thoroughly, had another one just like it, but smaller, fitting neatly inside it, like jars that fit inside one another, and a third and a fourth, and four others. In fact, there were eight whorls ^{616e} altogether, lying inside one another, and their rims looked like circles when viewed from above. From the back, these formed the uniform surface of a single whorl, centred on the shaft which had been driven right through the centre of the eighth whorl. “The first and outermost whorl had the widest circular rim, the rim of the sixth was second, that of the fourth was third, that of the eighth was fourth, that of the seventh was fifth, that of the fifth was sixth, that of the third was seventh, while that of the second was eighth. The rim of the largest whorl was spangled, that of the seventh was brightest, while the rim of the eighth derived ^{617a} its colour from the seventh which shone upon it. The colours of the second and fifth were quite similar to one another and yellower than the previous two, the third had the whitest colour, the fourth was reddish, while the sixth was the second whitest. “Although the whole spindle revolved, turning with the same motion within the overall revolution, the seven inner circles revolved gently in the opposite direction to the overall revolution.

^{617b}

Of these inner circles, the eighth travelled fastest; second fastest in pace with one another were the seventh, sixth and fifth. The fourth moved third fastest and it seemed to them to be revolving backwards. The third was fourth fastest and the second was fifth. The spindle turned in the lap of Necessity, and perched on top of each of the circles was a Siren, revolving along with the circle, sending forth a single sound on a single note, and from them all, all eight, came a single concordant harmony. There were three other women round about, at an

equal distance from one another, each ^{617c} seated upon a throne. These were the Fates, Lachesis, Clotho and Atropos, the daughters of Necessity, dressed in white with garlands upon their heads, singing in harmony with the Sirens. Lachesis sang of what had come to pass, Clotho of things that are, Atropos of what is to come.

^{617d}

Clotho, with a touch of her right hand, was helping turn the outer revolution of the spindle, pausing from time to time, while Atropos, with her left hand, did the same for the inner revolutions, and Lachesis lent a hand to each revolution in turn, with each hand in turn. “Now, once they had arrived, they had to go immediately to Lachesis, where a prophet first divided them into ranks, then took tokens and patterns of lives from the lap of Lachesis, ascended a lofty platform and proclaimed, ‘This is the word of Lachesis, maiden daughter of Necessity. Souls that live for a day, now begins another death-bearing cycle for your mortal race. No daimon shall be assigned to you by lot, but you shall choose your daimon. Let the one who is allotted first place be the first to choose a life which he will, necessarily, abide by. Excellence has no master, but each will have more of it or less of it as he honours it or dishonours it. The responsibility lies with the one who chooses. God is not responsible.’

^{617e}

“Having said all this, he threw down the lots among them all and each picked up the one that fell beside him, except for Er, who was forbidden to do so, and the number that each had drawn was obvious to the person who had picked it. After this he proceeded to place the patterns of lives on the ground in front of them, and there were many more of these than the number of people present. There were lives of every variety, for lives of all living creatures, and indeed all human lives, were included. There were tyrannies among them, some that endure to the end, others that are destroyed in the middle of their

course, ending in poverty, exile or beggary. There were lives of famous men, some famous for their appearance and beauty and for their general strength and prowess, some for their lineage and the excellence of their ancestors, while others were infamous for the same reasons. The same applied to women too. But because of the requirement that a soul become a different kind of soul by choosing a different life, the arrangement of soul was not inherent. But everything was commingled with everything else, and with wealth, poverty, disease and health, and anything in between.

618a

“And this, dear Glaucon, it seems is the moment of extreme danger for a human being, and because of this we must neglect all other studies save one. We must pay the utmost attention to how each of us will be a seeker and student who learns and finds out, from anywhere he can, who it is who will make him capable and knowledgeable enough to choose the best possible life, always and everywhere, by distinguishing between a good life and a degenerate one. Who will make him know- 618b edgeable enough to know what bad or good will be brought about by beauty when it is combined with poverty or prosperity, along with what sort of disposition of soul, doing so by taking account of everything we have mentioned and how their combinations with one another, and separations from one another, contribute to the excellence of a life? Who will make him knowledgeable enough to know what is brought about by the various inter-combinations with one another of good or evil birth, private station or public office, strength or weakness, ease of learning or difficulty in learning, 618c and everything else like this that belongs naturally to the soul, or is acquired? He will do all this so that he is able to make his choice reasonably, between the worse life and the better one, by looking to the nature of the soul and calling the life that leads soul to become more unjust, the worse life, and the one that leads it to become more just, the

better life. All other studies he will set aside, for we have seen that in life and after death this is the supreme choice.

618d

“He must go then to Hades holding to this view with an unbreakable resolve, so that even there he would not be dazzled by wealth and other such bad influences, fall in with tyrannies and activities like that, inflict a whole host of incurable evils, and experience even greater evils himself. He would decide, rather, that he should always choose the life that is midway between such extremes, and flee the excesses from either direction as best he can in this life and in all that is to 618e come, for that is how a human being attains the utmost happiness. And, indeed, the messenger 619a from there reported that the prophet then said, ‘Even for the person who comes up last but chooses intelligently and lives in a disciplined way, an acceptable life rather than a bad one awaits. The first to choose must not be careless, and the last must not be despondent.’

619b

“He said that once the prophet had made this announcement, the person who had been allotted first place came up immediately and chose the most extreme tyranny. Out of stupidity and 619c greed, he had made his choice without considering all the details properly, so he did not notice that it involved being destined to devour his own children, and other evils. Once he had time to look at it, he beat his breast and lamented his choice, without being true to the earlier pronouncements of the prophet, for he did not blame himself for the evils, but chance and the spirits and everything else except himself. He was one of the people who had come from the heaven and had 619d lived his previous life under an orderly system of government, where any share of excellence he had came from habit in the absence of philosophy. And, generally speaking, those who had come from the heaven were more likely to be caught out in this way since they had no training in

dealing with suffering, while those who had come out of the earth, for the most part, having had experience of suffering themselves and having seen others suffer, did not make their choices in a hurry. This, and the element of chance from the lot, is why most souls undergo an interchange of what is good and what is bad. Yet if someone were to engage in philosophy, consistently, in a sound manner, ^{619e} whenever he comes back to live in this world, unless he is among the last to choose it is likely not only that he would be happy whilst here, but also that his journey from here to there, and back here again, would be a smooth journey through the heaven, rather than rough and underground. So say the pronouncements from the other realm.

^{620a}

“Indeed, he said that the scene as the souls each chose their lives was well worth beholding, for it was a pitiful, comical and amazing sight to see. In fact, most of them made their choice based upon the habits of the previous life. And so he saw the soul that had once been Orpheus¹²⁴ choosing the life of a swan out of hatred for womankind, because, having met his death at their hands, the soul was unwilling to be conceived and born of woman. He saw that Thamyras¹²⁵ soul had chosen the life of a nightingale, and he saw a swan changing its choice to the life of a human, and other ^{620b} musical animals acted in like manner. The soul that had been allotted twentieth place chose the life of a lion. This was the soul of Ajax,¹²⁶ son of Telamon, and it was fleeing from embodiment as a human because it remembered the decision over the armour of Achilles. Next came Agamemnon’s¹²⁷ soul. This soul, too, was hostile to the human race because of its past experiences, and so it changed to the life of an eagle. The soul of Atalanta¹²⁸ had been allotted a place in the middle, and when it saw the huge honours that accompany the life of a male athlete, it could not ^{620c} pass this by, and so it grabbed that life. After this, Er saw the soul of Epeius,¹²⁹ the son of Panopeus, adopting the nature of a highly skilled woman. In

the distance, among the last to choose, he saw the soul of Thersites,¹³⁰ the joker, entering into a monkey. As it happened, the soul of Odysseus¹³¹ was allotted the last choice of all. When his turn came, he remembered all his former troubles, gave up the love of honour he had held previously, and went about for a long time seeking the life of an ordinary man with a private station. And he found it with difficulty, lying about somewhere, 620d neglected by everyone else. And he said when he saw it that he would have done the same thing even had he been given first choice, and he chose it gladly. And similarly, the other beasts entered into human beings or into one another; the unjust changed into wild creatures, while the just changed into tame ones, and there were mixtures of all sorts.

620e

“Now, once all of the souls had chosen their lives, they went up to Lachesis in the allotted order and she sent them on their way, with the daimon that each had chosen as the guardian of the life who fulfils what has been chosen. The guardian first led the soul to Clotho to ratify the fate it had chosen, as allotted beneath her hand as she turned the revolving spindle. Once the fate had been confirmed, the guide led it on again to Atropos and her spinning to make the web of destiny 621a unalterable. From there it went, inexorably, beneath the throne of Necessity, and when it had gone through, since the others had also gone through, they all proceeded to the Plain of Forgetfulness through terrible burning, stifling heat, for the place is devoid of trees or anything that springs from the earth. Evening was coming on by then, so they encamped beside the River of Heedlessness, whose water no vessel can contain. Now, it was necessary for all of them to drink a measure of the water, but some, who were not protected by wisdom, drank more than the measure, and as he drank, each forgot everything.

621b

“When they had fallen asleep, at midnight there was thunder and an earthquake, and each was suddenly borne upwards, this way and that, to their birth, like shooting stars. He himself had been prevented from drinking the water, yet he did not know by what manner or means he arrived back in the body, but he suddenly looked about and saw himself already lying on the funeral pyre at dawn.

621c

“And that, dear Glaucon, is how the story was saved and not lost, and it may save us too if we heed its advice, and we shall safely cross over the River of Forgetfulness without defiling our soul. But if we are persuaded by me, we shall regard the soul as immortal and capable of bearing everything bad, and everything good too, and we shall hold always to the upward path, practising justice, 621d accompanied by wisdom, in every way possible so that we may be friends to ourselves and to the gods, both during our stay here and when we receive the rewards of justice, carrying them off like prize-winners in the games, and both here and in the journey of a thousand years that we have described all may be well with us.”

NOTES

1. Glaucon, son of Ariston, was Plato's older brother.
2. This is a reference to the Thracian lunar goddess Bendis, a cult to whom had recently developed in the Piraeus, a harbour town and the main port of Athens.
3. Adimantus, son of Ariston, was an older brother of Plato.
4. Lysias was a famous speechwriter and orator. In Plato's *Phaedrus*, the eponymous character is depicted as having come from a conversation with Lysias.
5. Thrasyarchus was a sophist from Chalcedon who is also mentioned in Plato's *Phaedrus*.
6. Clitophon was an oligarch and statesman. There is a potentially spurious Platonic dialogue that bears his name.
7. Cephalus was a wealthy Syracusan arms manufacturer who lived in Athens.
8. *Iliad* xxii.60, xxiv.487; *Odyssey* xv.246, 348, xxiii.212.
9. *Odyssey* xvii.218.
10. Sophocles was an Athenian tragedian.
11. Themistocles was an Athenian politician and general.
12. Pindar was a lyric poet from Thebes who lived a generation before Plato. Fragment 214, Snell.
13. Simonides was a lyric poet from the island of Ceos. One of his poems serves as a basis for discussion in Plato's *Protagoras*.
14. *Odyssey* xix.392-398.
15. Bias of Priene was a wise man renowned for his probity. Pittacus was a military general from Mytilene on the island of Lesbos. Bias and Pittacus were two of the Seven Sages of Greece, a group of 7th-6th-century philosophers and statesmen who were known for their wisdom.
16. Periander, Perdiccas and Xerxes were tyrants from Greece and Persia. Ismenias was a Theban politician who managed to amass a great deal of money.
17. Pancration was a sport that combined boxing and wrestling.
18. Gyges was a king of Lydia, a kingdom in Asia Minor. The story Glaucon tells is about an ancestor of Gyges and his rise to the Lydian throne.

Herodotus, *Histories* 1.8-13 tells a different story of Gyges' rise to power.

19. Aeschylus, *Seven Against Thebes* 592-594. The quote is elaborated and expanded below.

20. *Odyssey* xvi.97-98.

21. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 323 ff.

22. *Odyssey* xix.109 ff, Lattimore.

23. Musaeus of Athens was a legendary poet and polymath who was closely associated with the religious mysteries. He is also mentioned in Plato's *Apology* (41a).

24. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 287-289.

25. *Iliad* ix, 497-501.

26. Selene was goddess of the moon.

27. Archilochus was a lyric poet from the island of Paros who was known for his versatile use of poetic metre. The reference here is to his fable about a fox and a hedgehog.

28. Hesiod, *Theogony* 154-210, 453-506.

29. The first three quotes are from *Iliad* xxiv.527-532. The source of the fourth quote is unknown.

30. Athena is depicted encouraging Pandarus to violate oaths at *Iliad* iv.73-103. This Aeschylus quote is of unknown origin.

31. This is likely a reference to works of Aeschylus in a play called *Niobe*, only fragments of which survive.

32. *Odyssey* xvii.485-486.

33. Inachos was a river god and king of Argos. The source of the line quoted here is unknown.

34. In *Iliad* ii.1-34, Zeus sends a dream to Agamemnon with the false promise of victory if he lays siege to Troy immediately. The source of the Aeschylus quote is unknown. Trans. Shorey; Loeb edition of the *Republic*.

35. *Odyssey* xi.489-491, Lattimore.

36. *Iliad* xx.64-65, Lattimore.

37. *Iliad* xxiii.103-104, Lattimore.

38. *Odyssey* x.494-495, Lattimore.

39. *Iliad* xvi.856-857, Lattimore.

40. *Iliad* xxiii.100-101, Lattimore.

41. *Odyssey* xxiv.6-9, Lattimore.
42. 'Cocytus' means lamentation and was the river of wailing in the underworld. 'Styx' means river of gloom and it formed the boundary between the earth and the underworld.
43. *Iliad* xxiv.9-12, Lattimore.
44. *Iliad* xviii.23-24, Lattimore.
45. *Iliad* xxii.414-415, Lattimore.
46. *Iliad* xviii.54, Lattimore.
47. *Iliad* xxii.168-169, Lattimore.
48. *Iliad* xvi.433-434, Lattimore.
49. *Iliad* i.599-600, Lattimore.
50. *Odyssey* xvii.383-384, Lattimore.
51. *Iliad* iv.412, Lattimore.
52. In our version of Homer, this is *Iliad* iii.8 and iv.431, Lattimore.
53. *Iliad* i.225, Lattimore.
54. *Odyssey* ix.8-10, Lattimore.
55. *Odyssey* xii.342, Lattimore.
56. *Odyssey* viii.266 ff.
57. *Odyssey* xx.17-18, Lattimore.
58. The source of these lines is unknown. Trans. Shorey.
59. *Iliad* xxii.15, 20, Lattimore.
60. *Iliad* xxiii.141-151, Lattimore.
61. *Iliad* xxiv.14-18.
62. *Iliad* xxiii.175.
63. Thought to be from Aeschylus' play *Niobe*, which survives only in fragmentary form. Trans. Shorey.
64. *Iliad* i.15-16, Lattimore.
65. The dithyramb was a hymn sung or danced in honour of the god Dionysus.
66. Marsyas was a satyr who challenged Apollo to a musical competition. Marsyas lost the competition and was flayed alive by Apollo.
67. Damon of Athens was a noted musicologist and teacher of Pericles.

68. *Iliad* xi.580, 828-836, and 624-650.
69. Herodicus was a renowned physician, sophist and gymnastic expert.
70. Phocylides was a gnomic poet from Miletus.
71. *Iliad* iv.218-219, Shorey.
72. Midas was a Phrygian king who, according to legend, could turn all he touched into gold.
73. Pindar, *Pythians* 3.55-58.
74. *Iliad* xvii.588.
75. Phoenicia was an ancient civilization located in modern-day Lebanon.
76. *Odyssey* i.351-352.
77. The Hydra of Lerna was a serpentine monster. The many heads of the beast were regenerative in that when one was severed, two would grow in its place. It was eventually killed by Heracles.
78. There was a tradition in the Greek world that Delphi was the centre of the earth. The spot was marked by a stone called the omphalos. The priestess of Apollo, the Pythia, would deliver her pronouncements from a hidden chamber within the temple of Apollo.
79. The four virtues were wisdom, courage, sound-mindedness or temperance, and justice.
80. *Odyssey* xx.17-18.
81. This question is eventually answered in Book VIII.
82. Adrasteia was a name for Nemesis, the goddess of vengeance, who exacts retribution against those who succumb to hubris.
83. This is a reference to the mythical story of the poet Arion who was fabled to have been kidnapped by pirates and rescued by a dolphin.
84. This is a variation on a line from Pindar, "plucking the unripe fruit of wisdom"; *Fragment* 209, Snell.
85. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 40.
86. *Iliad* vii.321.
87. *Iliad* viii.162.
88. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 122, Shorey.
89. The riddle, apparently, went as follows. A man, who is not a man, saw and did not see a bird that was not a bird in a tree that was not a tree; he hit and did not hit it with a stone that was not a stone. The answer was

that a eunuch with poor vision saw a bat on a rafter, threw a pumice stone at it and missed.

90. Plato coins this word using the Greek word for ‘opinion’ (*doxa*). It means ‘opinion loving’ in contrast to ‘wisdom loving’.

91. Momus was the personification of satire and mockery. His name is associated with blame and disgrace.

92. The phrase ‘necessity of Diomedes’ or ‘diomedan compulsion’ is thought to have come from a Homeric story according to which Diomedes, a great warrior, who had prevented Odysseus from killing him, decided against punishing Odysseus. Since Odysseus was so central to the defeat of Troy, the phrase came to refer to one who foregoes personal gain in the interest of the greater good.

93. The phrase ‘bridle of Theages’ later became proverbial for an undesired but perhaps fortunate restraint from doing something. See also the dialogue *Theages*.

94. Socrates tells us in the *Apology* (31c-32a) that his daimonic sign only admonished him not to do certain things.

95. It was reported that Heraclitus believed that the sun is new every day (Aristotle, *Meteorologica* 355a14).

96. *Iliad* i.131 and *Odyssey* iii.416.

97. The Greek for ‘interest’ and ‘offspring’ is the same. Socrates plays upon the dual sense of the word here. The pun extends to the end of Socrates’ statement where he plays upon the word ‘account’ as being either an interest calculation or the expression of a philosophical position.

98. There is a play here in the Greek text upon the words for sky and visible which is hard to capture in English and is omitted from this translation.

99. *Odyssey* xi.489-490.

100. Palamedes is depicted as a major figure in the events surrounding the Trojan War. It is he who discovered number and arranged the ranks of the army at Troy, counted the ships and everything else.

101. Daedalus was a skilled architect and craftsman, said to have sculpted figures so real that they appeared to live and move.

102. Solon was an Athenian statesman and legislator who is credited with laying the foundation for the Athenian democracy.

103. *Odyssey* xix.163.

104. *Iliad* xvi.112-113.

105. This text is difficult, and there is general disagreement about the value of Plato's 'entire geometrical number'. The most frequent value suggested is 216, but 3,600 and 12,960,000 have also been mooted.

106. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 109-202.

107. *Iliad* vi.211.

108. Possibly an adaptation of *Seven Against Thebes* 451.

109. Plutus, the god of wealth, was depicted by Aristophanes as having been blinded.

110. Herodotus 1.55. Croesus was a king of Lydia who was noted for his wealth. He asked the oracle at Delphi whether his reign would be long.

111. *Iliad* xvi.776.

112. Stesichorus was a lyric poet who was reputed to have been blinded for writing unflatteringly about Helen of Troy, and regained his sight after writing an encomium to Helen (the *Palinode*). In Stesichorus' *Palinode*, the combatants in the Trojan war actually went to battle over a phantom of Helen, while the real Helen went to Egypt.

113. Eriphyle accepted a necklace from Polynices, and in exchange persuaded her husband Amphiaraus to join the expedition of 'Seven Against Thebes', which led to his death. Eriphyle was ultimately murdered by her son Alcmaeon.

114. Asclepius was the god of medicine.

115. Lycurgus was a legendary statesman who is credited with the militaristic reform of Spartan society.

116. Charondas was a lawgiver who lived in Catania, Italy.

117. Solon was an Athenian statesman and lawgiver who is credited with laying the foundation for the Athenian democracy.

118. This refers to the contemporary rhapsodes who travelled around the Greek world reciting Homer's epic poems.

119. Thales of Miletus was a noted pre-Socratic philosopher and one of the Seven Sages. He was from Miletus in Ionia. Anacharsis was a Scythian philosopher from Scythia, which lay to the north of the Black Sea, who travelled to Athens. None of his works survives.

120. Creophylos was an epic poet from Samos or Chios and a contemporary of Homer. His name, which is odd, is formed from the Greek words for 'meat' and 'kind' or 'race'.

- 121.** Protagoras and Prodicus were influential 5th-century sophists.
- 122.** The ring of Gyges and the helmet of Hades were thought to confer invisibility upon the wearer.
- 123.** Tartarus is the abyss in which the wicked are tormented.
- 124.** Orpheus was a legendary bard, musician and prophet. He was supposedly killed by a group of Maenads, female followers of Dionysus, for not honouring the god.
- 125.** Thamyris was a legendary Thracian musician who boasted that he could beat the Muses in a competition. When he lost they blinded him and took away his ability to compose poetry.
- 126.** Ajax was a hero who was depicted in the *Iliad* as second only to Achilles in courage. After the death of Achilles, Ajax and Odysseus competed against one another for Achilles' armour. Ajax lost the competition and took his own life.
- 127.** Agamemnon was the king of Mycenae. He led the army against Troy after Helen, the wife of his brother Menelaus, was taken there by Paris.
- 128.** Atalanta was a huntress. It had been prophesied that marriage would be her undoing, so when her father attempted to arrange a marriage for her she stipulated that she would only marry one who could defeat her in a foot race. Eventually Hippomenes was able to beat Atalanta by tempting her with three golden apples provided by Aphrodite, who was offended by Atalanta's rejection of the love of the suitors.
- 129.** Epeius was credited with building the Trojan Horse with the help of Athena. The Warriors hid inside it and stormed the city. *Odyssey* viii.493.
- 130.** Thersites was an unremarkable soldier in the Achaean army during the Trojan War. In *Iliad* ii.211-277 he is depicted interrupting and berating Agamemnon as he is rallying the troops. In response, Odysseus beats and rebukes Thersites for his insolence.
- 131.** Odysseus was the king of Ithaca. He was a leading warrior for the Achaeans in the Trojan War. His ten-year journey back to Ithaca from Troy is recounted in Homer's *Odyssey*.

Sophist

ΣΟΦΙΣΤΗΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

THEODORUS a mathematician from Cyrene

THEAETETUS a young mathematician of Athens

SOCRATES of Alopece, son of Sophroniscus

STRANGER from Elea, follower of Parmenides and Zeno

scene: continuation of the Theaetetus, the day after that conversation

216a

Theodorus: Well, Socrates, as agreed yesterday,¹ we have come in person, and appropriately we are bringing this stranger, one of the people from Elea, an associate of those who follow Parmenides and Zeno.² He is a man with a great love of wisdom.

Socrates: In that case, Theodorus, are you unwittingly bringing in some god rather than a stranger, as Homer's phrase would have it, when he says that the gods in general, and the god of strangers in particular, become the companions of people who partake of true righteousness, to behold the excesses and the good order of humanity?³ So, perhaps this companion of yours may indeed be one of those higher powers, who is going to watch over and refute our sorry predicament in these arguments, as he is a god of refutation.

216b

Theodorus: That is not the manner of this stranger, Socrates. No, he is more moderate than those who take controversies seriously. Indeed, the man does not seem to me to be a god at all, though he is certainly divine, for I refer to all philosophers as divine.

216c

Socrates: And rightly so, my friend. In fact, you could say that this kind is just as difficult to discern as that of the god. Because most people do not recognise them, they go in and out of the cities in all sorts of guises.⁴ And the actual philosophers, not the artificial ones, looking down from on high at the life of those

below seem to some quite worthless, and to others most precious. Sometimes they appear as statesmen, at other times as sophists, and then again to some people they give the appearance of being utterly insane. Now, if it is acceptable to our stranger, I would like to find out from him what the people in his country think about these, and what names they use.

217a

Theodorus: What are you referring to?

Socrates: Sophist, statesman and philosopher.

Theodorus: What do you want to ask? What exactly is puzzling you about them?

Socrates: This: whether they regard all of these as one or two, or, as the names imply, three, also distinguishing three kinds and applying a name individually to each.

217b

Theodorus: Well, I don't think that he is at all reluctant to give an account of these. But what does our stranger say?

Stranger: Just that, Theodorus. There is no reluctance at all, nor is there a problem stating that my people believe there are three. But to define what exactly each of them is would not be a simple or easy task.

Theodorus: Well now, Socrates, by chance you have introduced questions much like those we happened to be asking him before we came here, and he gave the same excuse to us at the time as he gave to you just now. However, he does say that he has heard enough, in detail, and has not forgotten it.

217c

Socrates: Then, stranger, do not deny us the first favour we ask, and tell us this much. Do you usually prefer to deliver a lengthy oration expressing what you wish to present to someone, in your own way? Or do you work through questioning, as Parmenides once did in my presence, as he expounded glorious

arguments when I was young, while he was, by then, quite an elderly man indeed?⁵

Stranger: Well, Socrates, this interactive approach is easier with someone who converses mildly and co-operatively, but otherwise it is better to do the talking oneself.

Socrates: Then you may select any member of the company you wish, for they will all respond gently to you, though if you take my advice you will choose one of the young men – Theaetetus here – or any of the others whom you prefer.

217d

Stranger: Socrates, I feel a certain shame now at our first encounter for not making conversation based on short word-for-word exchanges instead of expounding a lengthy and prolonged oration all by myself, or with a respondent, as though I were putting on an exhibition. In fact, there is more to this than one might imagine from your question, and any account of it must be an extremely lengthy one. Then again, it seems to me discourteous and uncivil not to oblige you and these people, especially when you express it in this way. As for Theaetetus, well I unreservedly accept him as a partner in discourse, based on my own previous conversation, and your present recommendation.

217e

Theaetetus: Go ahead, dear stranger, and, as Socrates says, you will be doing us all a favour.

Stranger: There is probably no more to be said on these issues, and from now on the discussion should be with you, Theaetetus. So, if the length of it causes problems, do not blame me for that. Blame these friends of yours instead.

Theaetetus: Well, at the moment I don't think I shall give up on that account. However, if something like that does happen, we could involve Socrates here, the namesake of 'the' Socrates, as

he is the same age as I am, we train together, and he is well used to working with me.

218a

Stranger: Well said, and you can make that decision for yourself as the discussion proceeds. But you and I should now investigate this together, beginning firstly, I believe, with the sophist, searching and clarifying through argument what precisely he is. Indeed, at the moment our only common possession is his name, though perhaps we have the function upon which we both confer that name, privately within ourselves. But we should always come to agreement on the issue itself through arguments rather than a mere name in the absence of argument. We intend to investigate this kind, the sophist, but it is not the easiest thing in the world to comprehend what precisely he is. Now, whenever major issues need to be worked out properly, everyone has traditionally agreed that in such circumstances we should practise first with small and simple things before moving on to the greater. So now, Theaetetus, I am advising us, in view of the difficulty and elusiveness of the sophistic kind, to practise the method first on something simpler, unless you can suggest an easier way.

218d

Theaetetus: No, I cannot.

218e

Stranger: In that case, do you want us to resort to some ordinary example, and attempt to position it as a model for what's more important?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: Well then, what should we choose first as something minor and well known, and yet having an account no shorter than the important items? What about an angler, since he is readily recognisable to everyone without being of any great significance?

Theaetetus: Just so.

219a

Stranger: Well, I hope he provides us with a method and an account that is suitable to our purposes.

Theaetetus: That would be good.

Stranger: Come on, let's begin as follows. Tell me whether we should propose that he is a skilled person or someone who is unskilled, but has some other power.

Theaetetus: He is certainly not unskilled.

Stranger: Well then, all skills belong basically to two forms.

Theaetetus: How so?

219b

Stranger: Farming and the general care of any mortal creature, also the assembling or moulding of what we call household goods, and the imitative skill, may all be most properly referred to by a single name.

Theaetetus: How? What is it?

Stranger: When a person brings something into being which previously was not, we usually say that he who brings it into being produces it, and whatever is brought into being is produced.

Theaetetus: Correct.

Stranger: And the power of everything we just mentioned is directed towards production.

Theaetetus: That is indeed their direction.

Stranger: Then we may refer to these by the general term 'productive'.

219c

Theaetetus: We may.

Stranger: Now, besides this, there is the whole form that includes learning, knowledge acquisition, finance, sport and hunting. Although none of these actually manufacture anything, some manipulate by speech and action what has come into being or already exists, while others prevent anyone else from manipulating them. On this basis, all these subdivisions may very properly be said to constitute an acquisitive skill.

Theaetetus: Yes, that would be appropriate.

219d

Stranger: Then, since all skills are either productive or acquisitive, in which of the two should we place angling, Theaetetus?

Theaetetus: In the acquisitive. I suppose that is obvious.

Stranger: But are there not two forms of the acquisitive, one being an exchange between willing participants through gifts, hire or purchase, while the rest includes all manipulation based upon word or deed, and this would be the manipulative skill?

Theaetetus: It appears so anyway, from what has been said.

Stranger: But what about this? Shouldn't the manipulative skill be divided into two?

Theaetetus: In what way?

219e

Stranger: By designating all overt manipulation as competitive, and all manipulation by stealth as hunting.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: However, it would be unreasonable not to divide hunting in two.

Theaetetus: Tell me how.

Stranger: By categorising it as the hunting of living or lifeless prey.

Theaetetus: Why yes, if there are indeed both.

220a

Stranger: How could there not be both? Though it is best to disregard the hunting of the inanimate, as it does not even have a name, except for certain parts of diving and other trifling activities of that sort. However, we should refer to the hunting of living creatures as animal hunting.

Theaetetus: So be it.

Stranger: Can't we also say, properly speaking, that animal hunting is twofold in form? One kind involving land animals is divided into many forms and names, while the other includes the swimming creatures and is generally called water animal hunting.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

220b

Stranger: Now, we observe that one class of swimming creatures has wings, while the other lives in the water.

Theaetetus: Obviously.

Stranger: And the hunting of the winged kind is generally referred to as fowling, I suppose.

Theaetetus: Yes, that's what it's called.

Stranger: While the hunting of the water dwellers is, in general, termed fishing.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: What about this? Can't we also divide this hunting again into two broad significant parts?

Theaetetus: Based upon what?

220c

Stranger: Based on whether they conduct the hunt with traps or by striking.

Theaetetus: What do you mean? And how do you distinguish between these?

Stranger: Well, whatever encloses something, and completely surrounds it to imprison it, may properly be called a trap.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: So, baskets, nets, snares, nooses and the like must obviously be referred to as traps.

Theaetetus: Indeed.

Stranger: Then we shall say that this part of hunting is trapping, or something of that sort.

Theaetetus: Yes.

220d

Stranger: But, Theaetetus, hunting effected by impact with hooks or tridents is different from this, and should now be referred to by the single word 'striking', unless someone has a better suggestion.

Theaetetus: Let's not bother about the name, this one will suffice.

Stranger: Well, I believe that striking that occurs at night by firelight is referred to by the hunters themselves as fire-hunting.

Theaetetus: It is, indeed.

Stranger: While striking conducted in daylight is generally termed barbing, as both the tridents and the hooks are barbed at the tip.

Theaetetus: Yes, that's what it is called.

220e

Stranger: Now, this striking by barbing, when performed from above upon prey which is below, is called tridentry, I believe, as it is usually done using tridents.

Theaetetus: Well, that's what some people call it.

Stranger: However, there is, so to speak, only one form still left.

Theaetetus: What is it?

221a

Stranger: The kind which delivers the blow which is opposite to the trident and is effected with a hook, but not to any random part of the body of the fish, but always to the head and mouth of the victim, pulling him upwards from below with rods or sticks. By what name shall we say this process should be called, Theaetetus?

Theaetetus: Well, we proposed earlier that we needed to discover something, and I think our search has just been concluded.

221b

Stranger: So, now you and I have come to agreement not just about the name of angling, but we have also acquired a satisfactory account of the function itself. Indeed, from the totality of skills, one half was acquisitive, half of the acquisitive was manipulative, and half of manipulative was hunting. Half of hunting was animal-hunting, and half of animal-hunting was water animal-hunting. The lower division of water animal-hunting was fishing, and half of fishing was striking, and half of striking was barbing. Now, the barbing by a blow which pulls upwards from below has a name which reflects this activity, and this is the angling for which we have been seeking.

221c

Theaetetus: Yes, that has certainly been made abundantly clear.

Stranger: Come now, let's try to find out what exactly a sophist is, based upon this model.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: Now, the first question we asked was whether we should regard the angler as an ordinary man, or as someone with a skill.

Theaetetus: Yes.

221d

Stranger: And shall we now propose, Theaetetus, that this other man is an ordinary man, or in truth utterly wise?

Theaetetus: He is certainly not an ordinary man. However, I understand what you mean, as he falls far short of the wisdom which his name implies.⁶

Stranger: But it seems we must propose that he has some skill.

Theaetetus: Well, in that case, what precisely would it be?

Stranger: By the gods, have we ignored the fact that this man is related to the other man?

Theaetetus: Who is related to whom?

Stranger: The angler to the sophist.

Theaetetus: In what way?

Stranger: To me they are both quite obviously hunters of some sort.

221e

Theaetetus: What is the hunt of the sophist? We have said what the other man hunts.

Stranger: We somehow divided all hunting into two parts just now, one of swimming creatures and the other of land creatures.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: And we went on to discuss those swimming creatures who live in water, while we left the land animals undivided, though we said there were many forms.

222a

Theaetetus: Certainly.

Stranger: So, beginning with the acquisitive skill, the sophist and the angler proceed together up to this point.

Theaetetus: So it seems, anyway.

Stranger: However, they diverge when it comes to animal hunting, and one will hunt animals in seas, rivers and lakes.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: While the other will hunt by land, and in quite different rivers of wealth and youth, which are like abundant meadows, in order to manipulate the creatures in them.

222b

Theaetetus: What do you mean?

Stranger: There are two significant parts of land animal hunting.

Theaetetus: What are they?

222c

Stranger: One is of the tame and the other of the wild.

Theaetetus: Is there any hunting of tame animals?

Stranger: Yes, if man is indeed a tame animal. But propose whatever you like, either that no animal is tame, or that some other animal is tame while man is wild, or that man is actually tame but in your opinion there is no hunting of men whatsoever. Make whatever one of these statements pleases you, and let that be our definition.

Theaetetus: Well, I believe that we are tame creatures, and I say that there is hunting of men.

Stranger: Let's declare that tame animal hunting also has a twofold division.

Theaetetus: On what basis is that said?

Stranger: By defining piracy, enslavement, tyranny, and everything military under the single heading of violent hunting.

Theaetetus: Good.

222d

Stranger: And by then referring to skill in winning court cases, speaking to crowds, and general conversation, all together, as the single skill of persuasion.

Theaetetus: Correct.

Stranger: Now, we should say that there are two kinds of persuasion.

Theaetetus: What are they?

Stranger: One operates in private, the other in public.

Theaetetus: Yes, each of these does constitute a form.

Stranger: Now, isn't the hunting of private persons, for its part, either reward-accepting or gift-bearing?

Theaetetus: I do not understand.

Stranger: It seems you have not yet paid attention to the hunting carried out by lovers.

Theaetetus: To what aspect?

222e

Stranger: That besides everything else, they bestow gifts on those whom they hunt.

Theaetetus: Very true.

Stranger: Well, let this form then be called the skill of love.

Theaetetus: Certainly.

Stranger: But the form which accepts reward converses for the sake of gratification, and lays its bait entirely through pleasure, demanding only its own sustenance as a reward. And I think we would all refer to this as flattery, a skill in making things pleasant.

Theaetetus: Yes, what else could it be?

223a

Stranger: However, when it professes to carry on its discourse as though for the sake of excellence, and exacts a financial reward, doesn't that kind deserve a different name from the previous one?

Theaetetus: Yes, it must.

Stranger: What name? Try to say.

Theaetetus: Well, it's obvious. Indeed, we seem to me to have discovered the sophist. So, having said that, I think I would be calling it by the appropriate name.

223b

Stranger: Then it seems, Theaetetus, based on the present account, that what must be referred to as sophistry is an acquisitive skill of hunting live, land-dwelling prey, hunting humans privately for money payment, which seems to be educational, and is a hunt for rich and famous young men. That is what our current argument concludes.

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

Stranger: Let's take a further look at this. For what we are pursuing belongs to no ordinary skill but to an extremely variegated one. And, indeed, in our previous deliberations, the appearance is given that it is not what we are now saying it is,

but is a different kind.

223c

Theaetetus: In what way?

Stranger: The acquisitive skill somehow was a twofold form, one part was hunting and the other exchange.

Theaetetus: It was, indeed.

Stranger: Should we now declare that there are two forms of exchange, one based on gifts, the other on purchase?

Theaetetus: Let's say so.

Stranger: And we shall actually go on to say that purchasing is divided in two.

223d

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: By distinguishing between the sale of one's own productions, which is 'self-selling', and dealing in the productions of others, which is barter.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: What about this? Don't we refer to barter within the city, which is roughly half of it, as retailing?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: And the barter between one city and another, by sale and purchase, as trading?

Theaetetus: Of course.

223e

Stranger: Have we not observed that there is trading which, in one case, exchanges for money whatever sustains and provides for the body, and, in another case, whatever sustains and provides for the soul?

Theaetetus: What do you mean by that?

Stranger: Perhaps we don't recognise this in relation to the soul, though we do presumably understand the other instance.

Theaetetus: Yes.

224a

Stranger: Well, let's speak about music and skills in general, which are constantly going from city to city, being bought in one place, brought somewhere else and sold. Paintings, entertainments and much else besides are brought in and sold, some for the delight, others for the more serious intent, of the soul. Now, a buyer or seller of these has as much right to be called a trader as those who sell food and drink.

Theaetetus: What you say is very true.

224b

Stranger: And shouldn't a man who buys up items of knowledge, and goes from city to city exchanging them for money, also be called by the same name?

Theaetetus: Quite emphatically.

Stranger: Now, one part of this trading for the benefit of the soul may properly be called exhibiting, and the other part is just as ridiculous, but nevertheless, since it is the actual sale of knowledge, it must be assigned a name relevant to this activity. Is this not so?

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

224c

Stranger: Therefore, the part of this knowledge-selling which relates to the subjects of the other skills should be called that, while the part which deals with the subject of excellence should be called something else.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: Well, in the case of the other subjects, skill-selling would be an appropriate name. Now, you must try to give the

name of the part which deals with excellence.

Theaetetus: Indeed, it is the very object of our search! What other name could you safely utter? It is the sophistic kind.

224d

Stranger: None other. Come on, we shall summarise this now by saying that sophistry has made its second appearance as part of the acquisitive skill, which exchanges by purchasing through trading, which is for the benefit of the soul, and traffics in words and knowledge concerning excellence.

Theaetetus: Exactly.

224e

Stranger: Actually, I think you have a third instance. For if one of them settled down in the city and proposed to make a living by buying some knowledge, and also fabricating his own knowledge on the same subjects, and making sales, presumably you would call him by the exact same name as you used just now.

Theaetetus: I would have to.

Stranger: And so, the part of the acquisitive skill which involves exchange by purchasing, whether by retailing or self-selling, in either case whatever involves selling knowledge in this way, you would presumably refer to, always, as sophistic.

Theaetetus: I must, for I need to keep following the argument.

225a

Stranger: Then let's proceed to consider if the kind which we are pursuing actually bears a resemblance to something like this.

Theaetetus: Like what?

Stranger: We said that the acquisitive skill had a competitive part.

Theaetetus: Yes, we did.

Stranger: So, quite predictably, we divide it in two.

Theaetetus: Tell me how it is done.

Stranger: By designating one part as contentious and the other as combative.

Theaetetus: That's it.

Stranger: Is it quite reasonable and appropriate then, to assign a name such as 'violent' to the part of the combative which pitches bodies against one another?

Theaetetus: Yes.

225b

Stranger: And when it is one argument against another, what else can we call it, Theaetetus, except disputatious?

Theaetetus: Nothing.

Stranger: And we should propose that the part concerned with disputes is twofold.

Theaetetus: How so?

Stranger: Well, when it is conducted in public, with one long speech opposing another, and the concern is justice and injustice, then it is a judicial dispute.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: However, when it is done in private, and has been broken up into questions and answers, is there anything else we usually call it except contradiction?

Theaetetus: Nothing.

225c

Stranger: And the sort of contradiction which argues about contracts and proceeds at random and without skill, this should

be designated as a particular form, since the discussion recognises it as separate. However, our predecessors never gave it a name, nor would it be worth our while to do so now.

Theaetetus: True, for it has such minute and multifarious sub-divisions.

Stranger: But when it does involve a skill, and disputes comprehensively about justice itself and injustice and about other matters, don't we usually refer to it as argumentative?

Theaetetus: What else could we call it?

225d

Stranger: Now, there is a form of the argumentative which wastes money, and a form which makes money.

Theaetetus: There certainly is.

Stranger: Well, let's try to say what names should be given to each of them.

Theaetetus: Yes, we should do that.

Stranger: Now, I think that when the pleasure of engaging in these leads to neglect of one's own affairs, and the speech affords no pleasure to the many people who hear it, then in my opinion it is nothing other than talkativeness.

Theaetetus: Yes, that's the sort of thing that is said about it.

225e

Stranger: Then, the opposite of this makes money from private arguments, and it is now your turn to try to name it.

Theaetetus: Indeed, what else can one say without falling into error, except that a wondrous creature has turned up again for the fourth time, the object of our pursuit, the sophist.

226a

Stranger: So, our argument has now revealed further that the sophist is none other than the money-making kind, as it seems,

belonging to the argumentative, contradictory, disputatious, combative, competitive skill in acquisition.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: Now do you see how true it is that this is a creature of many aspects who will not be "captured with one hand", as the saying goes?

Theaetetus: Then we must use both!

226b

Stranger: Yes, we must. And we should do this to the best of our ability by pursuing a particular mark of his. Tell me, then, do we have certain names for common household tasks?

Theaetetus: Indeed there are many, but what sort of tasks are you asking about?

Stranger: We refer to tasks such as filtering, sifting, sieving and winnowing.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: And in addition to these, there is dressing wool, spinning, adjusting the web, and we know countless other such terms which are involved in the skills. Is this so?

226c

Theaetetus: What quality of them do you wish to demonstrate when you give these examples and ask about them all?

Stranger: All of these terms somehow refer to discrimination.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: Then, according to my argument, we should assign one name to the single skill which is involved in them all.

Theaetetus: What shall we call it?

Stranger: Discrimination.

Theaetetus: So be it.

Stranger: Well, let's see if there is any way that we can proceed to discern two forms of this.

Theaetetus: You are asking me to think very quickly.

226d

Stranger: And yet in the distinctions we described, one separated worse from better, another like from like.

Theaetetus: When you put it like that it appears so anyway.

Stranger: Now, I do not have a name for the second one, but I do have a name for discrimination, which leaves the better and discards the worse.

Theaetetus: Say it.

Stranger: All such discrimination is, as I understand it, referred to by everyone as purification.

Theaetetus: Yes, that's what it is called.

226e

Stranger: And couldn't everyone see that purification has two forms?

Theaetetus: Given time, perhaps. However it is not obvious to me at the moment.

Stranger: Well, it is surely appropriate to comprehend the many forms of bodily purification under a single name.

Theaetetus: What are they? And what is this name?

227a

Stranger: There are those which apply to living creatures and effect purification within the body, making proper divisions by means of gymnastics or medicine, and outside the body through the process of bathing. These we regard as commonplace. There are also those affecting inanimate things which are cared for by

wool-dressing and adorning in general, and are given numerous trivial and apparently ridiculous names.

Theaetetus: Very much so.

227b

Stranger: They certainly are, Theaetetus. However, it is of no particular concern to the method based on arguments, whether purification by washing or medication benefits us much or little. For it endeavours to discern the inter-relation and non-relation of all the skills, with the aim of acquiring intelligence, and to that end it respects them all equally. Indeed, because of their similarity, this method does not believe that one is more ridiculous than another. And it does not regard a person as more important if he exemplifies his skill in hunting through generalship, rather than louse-catching, though it will probably regard him as more pretentious.

Now, let's go back to the question you asked. What name shall we assign to the collective capacities whose function is to purify living and lifeless bodies? And it will make no difference to this method whether the title sounds impressive or not, as long as it separates out whatever purifies the soul, and combines whatever purifies anything else. Indeed, if we do in fact understand its intention, this method has attempted to separate mental purification from the others.

227c

Theaetetus: But I do understand, and I agree that there are indeed two forms of purification, though one form is concerned with the soul, which is separate from the one concerned with the body.

Stranger: Really excellent! Now, listen to the next aspect, and try in turn to cut that form in two.

Theaetetus: I shall try to make this division on whatever basis you suggest.

Stranger: Do we say that vice in the soul is something different from excellence?

Theaetetus: What else could we say?

227d

Stranger: And purification was the casting aside of whatever was in any way base, leaving the other part.

Theaetetus: Yes, it was.

Stranger: So then, to whatever extent we discern any removal of badness from the soul, we may properly refer to that process as purification.

Theaetetus: Very much so.

Stranger: Now we should state that there are two forms of badness of the soul.

Theaetetus: What are they?

Stranger: One is like a disease in the body, while the other is like a deformity that arises.

Theaetetus: I do not understand.

Stranger: Perhaps you think that disease and discord are not the same?

Theaetetus: Again, I do not know how to respond to this.

228a

Stranger: Do you believe that discord is anything other than disagreement, born of some corruption, among naturally kindred elements?

Theaetetus: Nothing other.

Stranger: And is deformity anything other than the absence of measure, a characteristic which is ugly in every case?

Theaetetus: Nothing else.

Stranger: What about this? In the souls of base people, don't we observe that opinions are opposed by desires, spirit by pleasures, and reason by aversions, and that all these are opposed to one another?

Theaetetus: Very much so.

228b

Stranger: However, all of these are necessarily kindred.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: So, we shall be right in referring to vice as discord and disease of the soul.

Theaetetus: Absolutely right.

228c

Stranger: What about this? If things that partake of motion and have been assigned some target wander off that target with every attempt, and miss the mark, would we say that this happens to them through proper measure in relation to one another, or alternatively through lack of measure?

Theaetetus: Obviously through lack of measure.

Stranger: Now, we do know that any soul which is ignorant of anything is ignorant unwillingly.

Theaetetus: Very much so.

228d

Stranger: And, indeed, ignorance is nothing but the disordered thinking of a soul, intent upon truth, whose understanding goes astray.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: So we must propose that an ignorant soul is deformed and lacking in measure.

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Stranger: Now, there are, it appears, two kinds of badness in the soul. One, which most people call vice, is clearly a disease of the soul.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: The other they call ignorance, but they are unwilling to agree that it is a badness arising only in the soul.

228e

Theaetetus: It certainly should be conceded, though I doubted it now when you said that there are two kinds of badness in the soul, and that cowardice, lack of restraint, and injustice should all be regarded as a disease within us, while the many varieties of ignorance should be designated as deformity.

Stranger: Now, in the case of the body, aren't there two skills relating to the two conditions?

Theaetetus: What are the two?

229a

Stranger: Gymnastic for deformity and medicine for disease.

Theaetetus: Clearly.

Stranger: And when it comes to violence, injustice and cowardice, surely punishment is the skill which is naturally closer to justice than any other?

Theaetetus: Quite likely. At least that's what people think.

Stranger: What about the other case? Could anyone prescribe anything more appropriate than teaching to remedy ignorance in its entirety?

Theaetetus: Not at all.

229b

Stranger: Come now. Should we say that there is only one kind of teaching, or are there more, two of which are the most significant? Consider this.

Theaetetus: I am considering it.

Stranger: Well, I think the quickest way for us to find out would be as follows.

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: By seeing whether ignorance has somehow got a division in the middle of it. For if it is twofold, it is obvious that teaching must also have two parts, one corresponding to each kind of ignorance.

Theaetetus: Yes, but is the division we are now looking for becoming evident to you?

229c

Stranger: Well, I think I can discern a distinct form of ignorance which is extensive and problematic, and as weighty as all the other parts put together.

Theaetetus: What is it?

Stranger: Being of the opinion that you know something when you do not know. It is likely that this is how all mistaken thinking arises in everyone.

Theaetetus: True.

Stranger: And, indeed, it is only this form of ignorance which is given the name of foolishness.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

229d

Stranger: Now then, what should we call the part of teaching which does away with this foolishness?

Theaetetus: Well, stranger, I believe that the other part of it is called technical instruction, while this part, among ourselves in the city at any rate, is called education.

Stranger: Almost all the Greeks do the same, Theaetetus. However, we shall still need to consider whether education is completely indivisible, or has some subdivision worth naming.

Theaetetus: Yes, we should consider that.

Stranger: It seems to me that there is a way of dividing this further.

Theaetetus: On what basis?

229e

Stranger: There seems to be a part of teaching in discourse, which is a rougher method, and another one, which is smoother.

Theaetetus: Can we say what sort of methods they are?

Stranger: Well, there is the traditional method which fathers use towards their sons, a method still used by many today whereby they either get angry with them whenever they fall into error, or else resort to more gentle exhortation. This may in general most correctly be called didactic.

Theaetetus: So it is.

230a

Stranger: However some people, having considered this for themselves, seem to conclude that all ignorance is involuntary, that no one who thinks that he is wise will ever wish to learn about matters of which he thinks himself knowledgeable, and that after a lot of trouble, the didactic form of education accomplishes little.

Theaetetus: A correct conclusion.

Stranger: Accordingly, they set about the eradication of this opinion in another way.

Theaetetus: What way?

230b

Stranger: They question him on matters about which he believes he is talking sense, when he is talking nonsense. They readily discover that his opinions are quite confused. So, by arguments, they gather the opinions together and place them side by side, and then they show him that these contradict themselves, about the same issues, in the same ways, and on the same basis. And those who recognise this become angry with themselves and gentle towards others, and they are liberated by this method from their exalted and fixed views about themselves. Their liberation brings the greatest delight to those who hear it, and constancy to those who experience it.

Indeed, dear child, the physicians of the body recognise that the body derives no benefit from any food it is offered until the internal impediments are first removed. So too these purifiers of the soul understand that the soul will obtain no advantage from any learning which it is offered until someone resorts to refutation, and brings the man who is refuted to a condition of humility where the impediments to learning have been removed, he is rendered pure, and he thinks that he knows only what he does actually know, and nothing more.

230d

Theaetetus: And this is surely the best and most sound-minded condition to be in.

230e

Stranger: Now, on account of all this, Theaetetus, we must also state that refutation is the greatest and most powerful of

purifications, and we must realise that the unrefuted man, even if he happens to be the Great King,⁷ is utterly unpurified, and is both uneducated and deformed, where a man who intends to be truly happy should be most pure and good.

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

231a

Stranger: Well then, what shall we call those who employ this skill? Indeed, I am afraid to say sophists.

Theaetetus: Why is that?

Stranger: In case I assign them too much honour.

Theaetetus: But surely the people we are discussing bear some resemblance to sophists.

Stranger: Yes, and so does a wolf to a dog, the fiercest animal to the tamest. And a cautious man must always be on his guard, especially when dealing with resemblances, for they are a most slippery class. Anyway, let them be called sophists, for I don't think that disputes over minor distinctions will arise once people are sufficiently vigilant.

231b

Theaetetus: No, it is quite unlikely.

Stranger: So let there be a purificatory part of the skill of discrimination, and from purification let us separate out the part which deals with the soul. Let teaching be part of this, and let education be part of teaching, and let us say that the part of education which brings about refutation of a vain presumption to wisdom turns out in our present argument to be nothing other than the noble kind of sophistry.

231c

Theaetetus: Well, let's say so. But on account of the multiplicity of manifestations, I am now perplexed about what exactly I should say that the sophist really is with any confidence that I

am speaking the truth.

Stranger: Your perplexity is to be expected. But you must also appreciate that the man himself is intensely perplexed by now as to how he will continue to evade this argument. Indeed, the proverb is right in saying that "it is not easy to escape all the grips of the wrestler". So now is the very best moment, and we must set upon him.

Theaetetus: Well said.

231d

Stranger: Well, now that we have stopped, let's catch our breath first, and while we are resting let's count up for ourselves how many times the sophist has appeared to us. Now, I think he was first discovered as the paid hunter of the young and wealthy.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: And secondly as a trader in things which are learned by the soul.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: And didn't he appear for the third time as a retailer of the same things?

Theaetetus: Yes, and for the fourth time selling his own knowledge himself.

231e

Stranger: Your recollection is correct. Now I shall try to remember the fifth. Indeed, he was a contestant in verbal competitiveness, specialising in the argumentative skill.

Theaetetus: He was, indeed.

Stranger: Well, although the sixth was actually disputed, we agreed nevertheless to propose that he is a purifier of souls from opinions that are an impediment to learning.

Theaetetus: Yes, entirely so.

232a

Stranger: Well, do you appreciate that when someone appears knowledgeable about many subjects but is called by the name of a single skill, this appearance is not sound? Rather, it is obvious that whoever experiences this in relation to any skill is unable to discern clearly that aspect of the skill that all these understandings look to. Consequently he assigns multiple names, rather than one, to whoever possesses them.

Theaetetus: It's likely that this happens in exactly the way you describe.

232b

Stranger: Let's ensure that it does not happen to us in our search, due to laziness. Rather, let us first take one of the statements about the sophist again, as there was one which did seem particularly revealing to me.

Theaetetus: Which one?

Stranger: We said that he was a contradictor.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: What else? Isn't he also a teacher of others, in this particular skill?

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed.

232c

Stranger: Let's consider this. In what realm do these men claim that they can turn people into contradictors? Our enquiry should begin as follows. Do they render people competent in contradicting about the divine realm which is unmanifest to the multitude?

Theaetetus: Well that is what people say, anyway.

Stranger: And what about the manifest realm of earth and sky, and the subjects associated with them?

Theaetetus: These too.

Stranger: In fact, whenever something is said in private gatherings concerning the entire field of becoming or being, we are aware, aren't we, that these men are brilliant at arguing against it, and they enable others to do the same.

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

232d

Stranger: And again, don't they also promise to enable people to dispute about laws, and affairs of state in general?

Theaetetus: Indeed, no one, or hardly anyone, would converse with them unless they made that promise.

Stranger: Indeed, for each and every skill, what is needed in each case to argue against the practitioner himself has presumably been composed, written down, and published for anyone who wishes to learn.

232e

Theaetetus: You seem to me to be referring to the writings of Protagoras,⁸ on wrestling and the other subjects.

Stranger: And of many others besides, blessed man. However, doesn't this skill in contradiction seem, in short, to be a power which is up to the task of disputation on all subjects.

Theaetetus: Well, there is nothing it seems to leave out.

233a

Stranger: Well, by the gods, child, do you think this is possible? For perhaps you young people may view this matter with more insight, while we older men are more dim.

Theaetetus: What matter? What exactly are you referring to? I do not quite understand what you are asking me now.

Stranger: Whether it is possible for a human being to know all things.

Theaetetus: In that case, stranger, the human race would indeed be blessed.

Stranger: Then how could someone who is not knowledgeable himself ever say anything worthwhile when he contradicts a person who knows?

Theaetetus: He simply cannot do so.

233b

Stranger: Well, what on earth can this wondrous sophistic power be?

Theaetetus: Wondrous in what way?

Stranger: In the way that they are somehow able to arm young people with the belief that they are wiser than everyone about everything. For it is obvious that if the sophists neither contradicted properly nor gave that appearance to the young, or again if they did give that appearance but were not regarded as more learned due to this disputatiousness, then according to you hardly anyone would want to pay money to become their pupils in these subjects.

233c

Theaetetus: Hardly anyone indeed.

Stranger: But nowadays they want to do this.

Theaetetus: Very much so.

Stranger: Presumably because the sophists are believed to be knowledgeable themselves with regard to whatever they contradict.

Theaetetus: That must be so.

Stranger: And are we saying that they may contradict every proposition?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: So they will appear to their pupils to be wise about everything.

Theaetetus: They must.

Stranger: But they are not, for this turned out to be impossible.

Theaetetus: Yes, it must be impossible.

Stranger: So our sophist has turned out to have an opinion-based knowledge about everything, but not truth.

233d

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly. And what we are now saying is probably the most accurate thing we have said about these fellows.

Stranger: Well, let's take a clearer example of this.

Theaetetus: What sort of example?

Stranger: As follows. Apply your mind to this and try to answer really well.

Theaetetus: Answer what?

Stranger: If someone were to maintain that on account of a single skill he knew not how to speak and argue, but how to do and make everything there is...

233e

Theaetetus: What do you mean by everything?

Stranger: You immediately fail to understand the point of what was said. In fact, it seems you do not understand the phrase 'everything there is'.

Theaetetus: No, I do not.

Stranger: Well, I am saying that you and I are included in 'everything', as well as all the other animals and plants.

Theaetetus: What do you mean?

Stranger: If someone said he was going to make you and me, and all the other creatures...

234a

Theaetetus: What could he mean by 'making'? Indeed, you are not actually referring to some sort of farmer, since you are also talking about a maker of animals.

Stranger: And also of sea and earth, sky and gods, and everything else there is. What's more, he makes them quickly and sells each of them for very little money.

Theaetetus: You are describing some sort of game.

Stranger: Indeed. Mustn't you regard it as a game when someone says that he knows everything and would teach this to someone else for a small sum in a short time?

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

234b

Stranger: And do you know of any form of game more skilled and elegant than that of imitation?

Theaetetus: Not at all. Indeed, you have proposed a very extensive form, all captured in a single word, more diverse than almost anything else.

Stranger: And so we appreciate that a man who professes to be able to make everything by means of a single skill, will be able to make imitations with the same names as the real objects by means of the skill in painting, and to deceive the less intelligent of the young children, who view the paintings from afar, into believing that he is entirely competent to complete any task he wishes.

234c

Theaetetus: How could he fail?

Stranger: Now, shouldn't we presume that there is some other skill involving words by which one could beguile the young through their ears with words, while they are still at a far remove from matters of truth, showing them verbal images of everything so as to make the statements seem true, and the speaker seem the wisest of all men on every issue?

234d

Theaetetus: Yes, there would be another skill like this, wouldn't there?

Stranger: Now, Theaetetus, most of those when they hear this, must, given enough time and advance in years, encounter things that are, and be compelled through their experiences to get a clear apprehension of things that are. This changes the opinions they once held, so that what was significant will appear trivial and what was easy will appear difficult, and all the illusions created by words will be turned completely upside down by the practical situations which they encounter. Is this so?

Theaetetus: Yes, as far as I can judge at my age anyway. But I believe that I am one of those who are "still at a far remove from matters of truth".

234e

Stranger: In that case, all of us here will try, and indeed are trying, to draw you as close as possible to the truth in the absence of these experiences. So now, tell me something about the sophist. Is it clear by now that he is a sort of beguiler who imitates things that are, or are we still hesitating, in case he truly possesses as many items of knowledge as the number of subjects on which he seems to be able to practise contradiction?

Theaetetus: How could he, stranger? No. It is fairly clear by now from what has been said, that he is one of the huge number of people involved in entertainment.

235a

Stranger: Well, in that case, we should propose that he is a beguiler and a sort of imitator.

Theaetetus: What else could we propose?

Stranger: Come now, our task at this stage is to make sure that the creature does not get away. Indeed, we have almost captured him in a sort of web of devices involving our statements about these matters. Consequently, he will never escape the next proposal.

Theaetetus: What is it?

235b

Stranger: That he is someone who belongs to the wonder-working kind.

Theaetetus: And I agree with that statement about him at least.

Stranger: It is accepted then that we should divide the image-making skill immediately, and descend into it, and if the sophist opposes us there, arrest him on the orders of lordly reason, hand him over to that king, and publicise his capture. But if he should somehow dive down into the subdivisions of the skill of imitation, we shall follow along, and continually divide the part which contains him until he has been caught. There is no way that this, or any other kind, will ever boast of escaping the method of those who are thus able to proceed in this way, based upon both the particular and the general.

235c

Theaetetus: Well said! We should do as you say.

Stranger: Now, based upon the process of division we have been using, it seems to me that I can now discern two forms of imitative skill, but I don't think that I can yet figure out which of them contains the object of our search.

Theaetetus: You should first say what the two forms are, and then make the division for us.

235d

Stranger: I can see one skill within it, the skill in making imitations. This is most in evidence when someone produces the imitation according to the proportions of length, breadth and depth of the original, with the appropriate colours being assigned to each part.

Theaetetus: Yes, but isn't that what all imitators try to do?

Stranger: Not in the case of those who somehow fashion or draw huge works of art. Indeed, if they were to give true proportions to the limbs, you know that the upper parts would appear smaller than they should and the lower parts larger, because one is viewed from a distance and the other from close up.

235e

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: So these craftsmen nowadays set the truth aside, and fashion into their images not the actual proportions, but those which will seem to be beautiful, do they not?

236a

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

Stranger: So, in the first case, where it is different but like, is it fair to call it a likeness?

Theaetetus: Yes.

236b

Stranger: And the part of the skill of imitation that deals with this should be called what we called it before, likeness-making.

Theaetetus: Yes, it should be called that.

Stranger: But what about something that appears to resemble the beautiful, because the viewpoint is unfavourable, but is not

like what it is said to be like, once someone is able to get a proper view of such an object? What should we call this? Well, since it appears to be like, though it is unlike, should we call it an appearance?

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed.

236c

Stranger: And isn't this very common in painting, and in imitation generally?

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: And wouldn't it be best if we referred to the skill which produces appearances rather than likenesses as appearance-making?

Theaetetus: Very much so.

Stranger: Now, these are the two forms of image-making I was talking about – likeness-making and appearance-making.

Theaetetus: Correct.

236d

Stranger: And yet, even now I am not able to see an obvious solution to the issue that bothered me earlier, in which of these two should the sophist be placed. Yes, the man is really wondrous, and extremely hard to catch clear sight of, since even now he has taken refuge very nicely and cleverly in a form which is hard to examine thoroughly.

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Stranger: Now, are you agreeing because you recognise this, or have you been drawn along by the force of the argument to agree quickly out of habit?

Theaetetus: How? What are you referring to?

236e

Stranger: We really are involved in an extremely difficult investigation, my friend. Indeed this appearing, and seeming without being, and saying things which are not actually true, all these are now full of difficulties, and they always have been. For it is extremely difficult, Theaetetus, to maintain that there really is false speech and false thinking, without being involved in contradictions as soon as this is said.

Theaetetus: What contradictions?

237a

Stranger: This statement has dared to propose that what is not, is. For otherwise falsehood would not have come into being. But, my boy, beginning when we were children up until his death, the great Parmenides emphasised this to us, stating in prose what he also says in verse.

*"Never shall this be proved that things that are not, are, but do thou, in thine enquiry, hold back thy thought from this way."*⁹

So that is the testimony of the great man. But in fact, the statement itself would reveal most if it were probed moderately. So first let's spend a while looking at this, if it makes no difference to you.

237b

Theaetetus: I accept anything you propose. So just proceed by considering how the argument may best unfold, and lead me also along that path.

Stranger: Well, that's what must be done. So tell me, would we dare to use the expression 'that which in no way is'?

Theaetetus: Well, why not?

237c

Stranger: If one of his pupils who had considered this were asked, not for the sake of argument or sport, but seriously, to tell us to what the expression 'what is not' should be applied, what do we think he would say? To what sort of thing would he apply the phrase himself? To what would he apply it, and how would he explain this to the questioner?

Theaetetus: You have asked a difficult question, and it is almost completely impossible for someone like me to answer it.

Stranger: Well, isn't it obvious in any case that the term 'what is not' may not be applied to any of the things that are?

Theaetetus: No, how could it?

Stranger: Then, since it is not actually applicable to what is, neither may it be applied to something.

Theaetetus: Indeed not.

237d

Stranger: And presumably it is clear to us that we always use the word 'something' in relation to what is, for it is impossible to use this word on its own, naked and isolated from all of the things that are. Is this so?

Theaetetus: Yes, it's impossible.

Stranger: Do you agree because you recognise that when speaking of 'something' we must be speaking of some one thing?

Theaetetus: That's right.

Stranger: Yes, indeed. And you will agree that 'some thing' indicates one, and 'some things' indicates two or many.

Theaetetus: How could I disagree?

Stranger: Well then, when not speaking of something, it is most necessary, it seems, that we are speaking of absolutely nothing.

Theaetetus: Yes, it is most necessary.

237e

Stranger: Could we ever agree that such a person is speaking at all, when he is speaking of nothing? No, we should not even say that a man is speaking when he tries to utter what is not.

Theaetetus: This argument should end our perplexity anyway.

Stranger: Don't make extravagant claims yet, my friend, for there are other perplexities. Indeed, the greatest and first of them actually relates to the very principle involved here.

Theaetetus: What do you mean? Speak, and do not hesitate at all.

Stranger: If we take something that is, I presume we may add to it something else that is.

Theaetetus: Of course.

238a

Stranger: But shall we say that it is ever possible to add anything which is, to what is not?

Theaetetus: No, how could we?

Stranger: Now, we include number in general among things that are.

Theaetetus: Well, if we propose that anything is, we must surely propose that number is.

Stranger: Therefore we should not even attempt to apply number, be it multiple or be it one, to 'what is not'.

238b

Theaetetus: Well, the argument does seem to indicate that it would not be appropriate to attempt this.

Stranger: How, then, could anyone either utter through the mouth, or in any way comprehend in thought, things that are

not, or what is not, in the absence of number?

Theaetetus: Tell me why not.

Stranger: Well, whenever we say 'things that are not', aren't we trying to attribute multiplicity of number to them?

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed.

Stranger: But whenever we say 'what is not', we attribute one in that case, do we not?

238c

Theaetetus: Well, that is very clear, anyway.

Stranger: And yet we have been saying that it is neither proper nor correct to try to attach being to non-being.

Theaetetus: What you are saying is perfectly true.

Stranger: Do you appreciate then that it is not possible to utter correctly, or speak of or think of non-being just by itself? It is rather unthinkable, unspeakable and unutterable, and there is no account thereof.

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

238d

Stranger: In that case, wasn't I mistaken earlier when I said that I was going to state the greatest perplexity involved here, when another even greater perplexity may be stated?

Theaetetus: What perplexity?

Stranger: You surprise me! Do you not realise from what has already been said, that 'what is not' reduces even the person who tries to refute it to such perplexity that it forces him to contradict himself on the issue?

Theaetetus: What are you saying? Make this a bit clearer.

238e

Stranger: Don't look to me for clarity. For although I am proposing that what is not must partake neither of one nor of many, I said, both then and now, that it is one, for I said 'what is not'. Do you understand?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: And what's more, I actually said a little earlier that it is unutterable, unspeakable, and there is no account thereof. Do you follow?

Theaetetus: Yes, of course.

239a

Stranger: So in trying to associate 'being' with this, am I not contradicting what I said before?

Theaetetus: It appears that you are.

Stranger: Then again, when I applied the word 'that' to it, wasn't I referring to it as one?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: And, indeed, in saying that there is 'no word' for it, and it is 'unspeakable' and 'unutterable', I used a statement that implies one.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: And yet we say that properly speaking it should not be defined as one, or many, or be called 'it' at all, for the use of this phrase would attribute the form of one.

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

239b

Stranger: Well, what is to be said about me? It turns out that the refutation of non-being is again defeating me. So, as I said, we should not look to my pronouncements for the correct manner of speaking about 'what is not'. Instead, let it be your turn, and let's consider what you say.

Theaetetus: What are you referring to?

Stranger: Since you are young, you should come before us, fair and noble, exert yourself, and try your very best to make some correct utterance about this without attributing being, or one, or numerical multiplicity to what is not.

239c

Theaetetus: It would be strange if I had any great desire to attempt this myself in the light of what has happened to you.

Stranger: Well, if that's what you think, then let's forget about you and me. Until we encounter someone who can do what I asked you to do, we should say that the sophist has very cunningly dived down into a place we cannot enter.

Theaetetus: That is certainly how it seems.

239d

Stranger: Well, in that case, if we say that he has some skill which involves appearances, he will readily attack us for this usage of words, and turn those words against us by asking what precisely we mean at all by 'image' when we refer to him as an image-maker. So consider, Theaetetus, how we should respond to this impetuous questioning.

Theaetetus: Obviously we are talking about images both in water and in mirrors, and also paintings, sculptures, and all the other varied productions of this sort.

239e

Stranger: Apparently, Theaetetus, you have never seen a sophist.

Theaetetus: Why do you say that?

Stranger: He will have you thinking that his eyes are shut or that he has no eyes.

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: If you were to answer him in that way and refer to mirror images or fashioned images, he would laugh at your words for speaking as though he was a man who could see. He would pretend that he recognised neither mirror nor water, nor had any sight at all, and would just ask you something about your words.

240a

Theaetetus: What would he ask about?

Stranger: In all these instances, and you say that there are many, you decided to employ a single word, and you used the word 'image' as one term applicable to all the instances. So defend this. Speak, and do not yield any ground to this fellow.

Theaetetus: Well, stranger, what else can we say an image is except another sort of object made like the true object?

240b

Stranger: Are you speaking of another sort of true object? Or what do you mean by 'sort of object'?

Theaetetus: It is not true at all, but like the true.

Stranger: Are you saying that the true object actually is?

Theaetetus: Just so.

Stranger: And what about this? Is the not true opposite to the true?

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: So, are you saying that the likeness actually is not, if you say that it is not true?

Theaetetus: Yet somehow or other it is.

Stranger: Though you are not saying that it truly is.

Theaetetus: Indeed not. However, it is actually an image.

240c

Stranger: So, while it actually is not, it is actually what we call an image.

Theaetetus: It really seems that something like this combines what is with what is not, and is very strange.

Stranger: Indeed, how could it be otherwise? And now you may see that our many-headed sophist, by means of this interchanging, has compelled us against our will to agree that what is not somehow is.

Theaetetus: I see it, indeed.

240d

Stranger: And now, shall we be able to define this skill of his without contradicting ourselves?

Theaetetus: In what way? What sort of contradictions are you afraid of?

Stranger: Whenever we say that he is deceiving us about the appearance, and his skill is one of falsification, shall we say that our souls form false opinion at that time, on account of the skill of this man? Or what precisely shall we say?

Theaetetus: That's it! What else could we say?

Stranger: What's more, false opinion will be thinking the opposite of things that are. Is this so?

Theaetetus: Just so. It will be thinking their opposite.

240e

Stranger: So are you saying that false opinion thinks things that are not?

Theaetetus: It must.

Stranger: Does it think that things that are not, are not? Or does it think that things that are not at all, somehow are?

241a

Theaetetus: Things that are not must somehow be, if anyone is ever to speak falsely, even a little.

Stranger: What about this? Doesn't false opinion also think that things that entirely are, are not at all?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: And this too is false?

Theaetetus: This too.

Stranger: And so I presume, on this basis, a statement will be considered false if it says that things that are, are not, or that things that are not, are.

Theaetetus: Yes, how else could a statement of this sort arise?

241b

Stranger: Hardly at all, but the sophist will deny this. Or is there any way that a right-minded person would accept these formulations in the light of what we agreed before? Do we understand what agreements are meant, Theaetetus?

Theaetetus: Indeed, how could we fail to understand? He will claim that we are saying the opposite of what we said a moment ago, once we dare to state that there is falsity both in opinions and based upon words. For we are constantly compelled to associate what is with what is not, despite having agreed just now that this is utterly impossible.

Stranger: Your recollection is correct. But now we really must consider what to do about the sophist. For you see that we are well supplied with many objections and perplexities, once we propose to track him down in the skill of falsification and beguilement.

Theaetetus: I do, indeed.

Stranger: And we have elaborated only a small portion of the problems which are almost limitless.

241c

Theaetetus: Well, if that is the case, it would seem to be impossible to capture the sophist.

Stranger: What next? Shall we become cowards, and give up now?

Theaetetus: I say that we should not do that if we are somehow able to get even the slightest grip on this fellow.

Stranger: Then you will have to be quite forgiving, and, as you have just said, be satisfied if we can somehow make even minor inroads against such a powerful argument.

Theaetetus: How could I refuse?

241d

Stranger: In that case, I have a further request of you.

Theaetetus: What is it?

Stranger: Do not presume that I am becoming some sort of parricide.

Theaetetus: What do you mean?

Stranger: It will be necessary in defending ourselves to probe the statement of Parmenides, our father, and force the assertion that in some respect what is not, is, and again what is, in some way, is not.

Theaetetus: It is evident that some such contention must feature in these discussions.

241e

Stranger: Yes, mustn't this be evident even to a blind man, as they say? For if these statements are neither refuted nor accepted, it will hardly be possible for someone to speak about false statements or false opinions being either images, likenesses, imitations or appearances – or to speak of any skills associated with them – without looking ridiculous by being

forced to contradict himself.

Theaetetus: Very true.

242a

Stranger: Well, for these reasons we must dare to attack the paternal maxim. Or if some scruple hinders us from doing this, we should abandon the matter entirely.

Theaetetus: Well, this should not hinder us at all.

Stranger: Then I shall still make a third small request of you.

Theaetetus: Just name it.

242b

Stranger: When I spoke just now, I indicated that I have always been daunted by the refutation of these, and this is especially so right now.

Theaetetus: You did say that.

Stranger: Now, I am afraid that because of what I have said, you will think that I am mad for changing my stance back and forth. After all, we are taking on the refutation of the proposition¹⁰ for your sake, if we do actually refute it.

Theaetetus: Well, in my opinion, there is no problem at all if you embark upon this refutation and proof. Have no concern on my account.

242c

Stranger: Come now, where should one begin this audacious discourse? Indeed, my boy, I think that there is a certain inevitable path for us to follow.

Theaetetus: What is it?

Stranger: We should first investigate the matters that seem clear to us now, in case we have somehow been confused about them, and yet agree with one another as readily as though we had a good understanding.

Theaetetus: Explain your meaning more clearly.

Stranger: It seems to me that Parmenides has conversed with us quite casually, and so has anyone who has ever set about specifying how many, and of what sort, are things that are.

Theaetetus: In what way?

242d

Stranger: Each of them appears to me to be telling us a story, as though we were children. One says that things that are, are threefold, and some of them on occasion conduct some sort of battle with one another, and at other times become friends, marry, have children and look after their offspring. Another says there are two factors, wet and dry or hot and cold, and he sets up a household for them and marries them off, while we Eleatic folk, beginning with Xenophanes or even earlier, recount our stories as though what we refer to as 'all things' are actually one. But some Ionian and, later, some Sicilian Muses consider it safest to combine both stories, and say that what is, is both many and one, and is held together by enmity and friendship.¹¹ "Though it is separating, it is continually combining", say the more severe of these Muses.¹² But the milder ones relaxed the requirement that it always be this way, and they say that it alternates, and that the all is sometimes one and is friendly on account of Aphrodite, at other times it is many and at war with itself due to some strife. Now, some of these men may have spoken the truth in all this, or they may not, though it is difficult and problematic to attribute such a serious failing to famous men of old. But we can say one thing without reproach.

242e

Theaetetus: What is it?

Stranger: That they have shown no regard for common folk, and they despise us. For each of them pursues his own line of

argument without considering at all whether we are following what they say or are being left behind.

Theaetetus: What do you mean?

243a

Stranger: Whenever one of them speaks and says that many or one or two is, or has become, or is becoming; or again, that heat is mixed with cold; or elsewhere proposes divisions and combinations; by the gods, Theaetetus, can you ever understand what they are saying? Indeed, when I was younger and someone mentioned what is not – the phrase that is puzzling us now – I thought I understood perfectly. But you see now just how perplexed we are about this issue.

243b

Theaetetus: I see.

Stranger: But when it comes to 'what is', the soul may well be in the grip of a similar predicament. We profess to be unconcerned about this and to understand this and not the other whenever someone mentions it, yet we may be equally perplexed about both.

243c

Theaetetus: Quite likely.

Stranger: And, indeed, the same may be said of anything else we discussed previously.

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed.

243d

Stranger: Well, we shall consider all those other matters later on, if you wish. But we must now investigate the important, fundamental and primary issue.

Theaetetus: Which one do you mean? Or is it obvious that you are saying that we must first examine 'what is', and what exactly those who use the phrase think that it indicates?

Stranger: You have understood precisely, Theaetetus. For I am saying that this is indeed the approach we should adopt. We should resort to close questioning, as though the men were actually present, and say, "Come on, all you who say that hot and cold, or any pairs like that, are all things. What precisely are you attributing to both when you say that both are and each is? What should we understand by this 'is' of yours? Is it a third factor in addition to the other two, and should we propose on your behalf that the all is no longer two but three? For presumably you do not take one of the pair and call it being, and say that both of them equally 'are', for in either case they would effectively be one and not two."

243e

Theaetetus: What you say is true.

Stranger: "Well then, do you want to call the pair of them being?"

Theaetetus: Perhaps.

244a

Stranger: Then we shall say, "But, friends, even with this formulation you would be stating unambiguously that the two are one."

Theaetetus: What you have said is absolutely correct.

Stranger: "Now, since we have become perplexed, you must clarify adequately, to our satisfaction, what precisely you wish to indicate whenever you use the word 'being'. For you have obviously known this all along, while we thought that we knew at one stage but have now become perplexed. So, explain this point to us first so that we may not presume to understand your doctrines when the very opposite is the case." Surely there would be nothing wrong, child, in saying these things, and putting them to these men, and to anyone else who maintains that all is more than one?

244b

Theaetetus: Not in the least.

Stranger: And what about those who say that the all is one? Shouldn't we find out, as best we can, what precisely they mean by 'being'?

Theaetetus: How could we do otherwise?

Stranger: Then let them answer this question. "Do you say that one alone is?" To which they will reply, "We do say so", won't they?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: "And is there something which you call being?"

Theaetetus: Yes.

244c

Stranger: "And is it what you call one? Are you using two names for the same thing, or how does this work?"

Theaetetus: What answer will they give next, stranger?

Stranger: Obviously, Theaetetus, it is not at all easy for someone who has proposed this hypothesis to respond to what we have just asked, or any other question for that matter.

Theaetetus: Why so?

244d

Stranger: Well, to agree that there are two names when you have proposed that there is nothing except one, is presumably ridiculous.

Theaetetus: Yes, it must be.

Stranger: And it would be altogether ridiculous to accept the assertion that there is a name, when it does not possess an account.

Theaetetus: What is ridiculous about it?

Stranger: Well, in proposing that the name is different from the object, he is presumably referring to two things.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: And, indeed, should he propose that the name is the same as the object, he will either be compelled to say that it is the name of nothing, or he will say it is the name of something, and the name will turn out to be the name of a name and of nothing else.

Theaetetus: Just so.

Stranger: And the one will be the name of one, as there is only one, and also the one of the name.

Theaetetus: It must be.

244e

Stranger: What about this? Is the whole different from what is one, or will they say it is the same as this?

Theaetetus: They will have to say it is the same, and they do say so.

Stranger: If it is a whole, and is, as Parmenides says, equally balanced in all directions from the centre, like the mass of a well-rounded sphere, for it must not be more in one place and less in another. Then, since what is is like this, what is will have a centre and extremities. And since it has these, it certainly must have parts, must it not?

245a

Theaetetus: So it must.

Stranger: Moreover, there is nothing to prevent whatever is divided into parts from having the characteristic of the one associated with all its parts, and in this way, being all, it could also be one whole.

Theaetetus: Why not, indeed?

Stranger: But isn't it impossible for something with these characteristics to be just the one itself?

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: Presumably what is truly one must be described as entirely without parts, according to the correct account.

Theaetetus: Yes, it must be.

245b

Stranger: But the sort of one which consists of many parts will not accord with this account.

Theaetetus: I understand.

Stranger: Now will 'what is' be both one and whole, as it possesses the character of the one, or should we utterly deny that 'what is' is a whole?

Theaetetus: That's a difficult choice you are offering.

Stranger: Well, that is certainly true. For 'what is', having been somehow characterised as one, will appear not to be the same as the one, and so all things will be more than one.

Theaetetus: Yes.

245c

Stranger: However, if 'what is' is not a whole on account of being characterised as one, and yet the whole itself is, then 'what is' turns out to be missing part of itself.

Theaetetus: Certainly.

Stranger: And based upon this argument, 'what is' will be non-being, as it is deprived of itself.

Theaetetus: Just so.

Stranger: Furthermore, all things become more than one, as both 'what is' and the whole have each acquired a separate, distinct nature.

Theaetetus: Yes.

245d

Stranger: But if the whole is not at all, then the very same applies to 'what is', and so in addition to its not being, it could never come into being either.

Theaetetus: Why so?

Stranger: Whatever has come to be has always come to be as a whole. Consequently, we cannot talk about being or becoming as if they are without including the one or the whole among things that are.

Theaetetus: That certainly seems to be the case.

Stranger: And, indeed, whatever is not a whole cannot be something with any number at all. For if it had number, whatever that number might be, it would have to correspond to that number as a whole.

Theaetetus: Precisely.

245e

Stranger: And, indeed, a myriad of other issues, each involving endless perplexities, will present themselves to anyone who maintains that 'what is' is either some two or only one.

Theaetetus: Yes, the issues that are now arising make this quite evident. One leads on to another, bringing a larger and more problematic lack of direction to whatever has already been said.

246a

Stranger: Now, we have not talked about everyone who gives a precise account of being and non-being, but let this be enough. Next, we should consider those who give a more general account, so that we may see, by reviewing them all, that it is no easier to say precisely what 'what is' is than to say what 'what is not' is.

Theaetetus: Yes, we should proceed to consider these too.

Stranger: And, indeed, there seems to be a sort of battle between gods and giants among them in their dispute with one another about being.¹³

Theaetetus: How?

246b

Stranger: Well, some are dragging everything from heaven and the unseen down to earth, literally grabbing trees and rocks in their hands. Indeed, they lay hold of all such objects and strenuously maintain that that alone is, which gives rise to some contact and touch. They define body and being as the same, and if any of the others say that there is anything without a body, they are utterly contemptuous and they want to hear no more.

Theaetetus: Yes, you are describing fearsome men, and indeed I myself have met many of them before.

246c

Stranger: Yes. That's why those who oppose them conduct their defence very cautiously, from above, from the unseen, maintaining forcibly that true being consists of certain bodiless forms which can be known by reason. And they gradually break the bodies of those other men into little pieces in their discussions, and what the others maintain to be true they refer to as a sort of becoming in motion, rather than being. And there is always a huge battle going on between both parties about these issues, Theaetetus.

Theaetetus: True.

Stranger: Then let's obtain, from both sides in turn, the account of being that they favour.

Theaetetus: How shall we obtain them?

246d

Stranger: It will be easier in the case of those who propose that being consists of forms, for they are gentler people. However, it

is more difficult, perhaps almost impossible, from those who drag everything by force to the physical. But I think they should be dealt with as follows.

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: The best thing would be to make better people of them, if that were somehow possible. But if this is not to be, let's make up a story, assuming that they would be willing to answer questions more fully than now. For agreement with reformed individuals will be preferable to agreement with worse. However, we are not interested in the people themselves. We are seeking the truth.

246e

Theaetetus: Quite so.

Stranger: Then call upon these reformed folk to answer you, and you should interpret what is said.

Theaetetus: I shall.

Stranger: Well, let them say whether they maintain there is such a thing as a mortal, living being.

Theaetetus: How could they deny this?

Stranger: And won't they agree that this is a body with a soul in it?

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

247a

Stranger: And do they include soul among things that are?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: What about this? Don't they agree that a soul can be just or unjust, and can be wise or ignorant?

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: But isn't it from the possession and presence of justice and wisdom that each of these souls becomes like this, while their opposites do the opposite?

Theaetetus: Yes, they agree with all this too.

Stranger: And they will surely agree that whatever is capable of being present or absent is something.

Theaetetus: They do say so.

247b

Stranger: So, if they accept that there is justice, wisdom and excellence in general, and their opposites, and also soul in which they arise, do they say that any of these is visible and tangible, or are they all unseen?

Theaetetus: Hardly any of these is visible.

Stranger: What about this? Do they say that anything of this sort has a body?

Theaetetus: They do not answer the entire question in the same way. Although they think that the soul has acquired a body of some sort, when it comes to wisdom and the other qualities you asked about, they are ashamed either to admit that these are not included among things that are, or to maintain emphatically that they are all physical.

247c

Stranger: Well, Theaetetus, we can see that these men have been reformed. For the original stock, their earth-born ancestors, would not have been ashamed of anything. Instead, they would insist that whatever they are unable to squeeze with their hands is nothing at all.

Theaetetus: Yes, you have expressed their attitude fairly well.

247d

Stranger: Then let's question them once more. Indeed, if they are prepared to concede that there is even a small non-physical

portion of things that are, that is sufficient. For they must explain the shared nature that has arisen simultaneously in the non-physical, and also in anything physical, with reference to which they say that they both are. Perhaps this may leave them perplexed. And if that is what happens to them, then consider this. Would they be willing to accept a suggestion from us and agree that 'what is' is as follows?

Theaetetus: What is the suggestion? Tell us and we shall know immediately.

247e

Stranger: Well, I am saying that anything actually is, once it has acquired some sort of power, either to affect anything else at all, or to be affected, even slightly, by something totally trivial, even if only once. Indeed, I propose to give a definition, defining things that are as nothing else except power.

Theaetetus: Then, since they do not have anything better to suggest right now, they accept this.

248a

Stranger: Very well, though perhaps a different suggestion may occur both to us or them later. For the present, let this stand as it has been agreed by both parties.

Theaetetus: Let it stand.

Stranger: Now, let us move on to the others, the friends of the forms, and you should interpret their doctrines for us too.

Theaetetus: I shall.

Stranger: "Presumably you make a distinction between becoming and being, and you refer to them as separate. Is this so?"

Theaetetus: "Yes."

Stranger: "And you say our communion with becoming is through the body, by means of sense perception, while it is by means of reasoning through the soul that we commune with actual being, which you say is always just the same as it is, while becoming is always changing."

248b

Theaetetus: "Yes. That is what we say."

Stranger: "Now, best of all men, the communing which you ascribe to both, isn't it what we mentioned a moment ago?"

Theaetetus: What was that?

Stranger: "An action or an effect arising from some power, from their coming together with one another." You probably do not hear their response to this so clearly, Theaetetus, but perhaps I can hear it, as I am quite familiar with them.

Theaetetus: What then? What account do they give?

248c

Stranger: They do not agree with what we said just now to the earth-born men about being.

Theaetetus: What was that?

Stranger: We somehow proposed an adequate enough definition of things that are: whenever the power to be affected or to affect, even to the slightest extent, is present in something, that something is something that is.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: Now to this they reply that the power to be affected and to affect is a feature of becoming, but they say that neither power attaches to being.

Theaetetus: Don't they have a point?

248d

Stranger: A point which makes us say that we still need to find out more clearly from them whether they also concede that the soul knows, and that being is known.

Theaetetus: They will surely assent to that.

Stranger: "What about this? Do you say that the knowing, or being known, is an action, an effect, or both? Or is one an action, and the other an effect? Or do neither of them have anything to do with action and effect?"

Theaetetus: Obviously they would say neither, otherwise they would be contradicting what they said before.

248e

Stranger: I understand. Instead, they would say that if knowing is indeed some action, it follows that whatever is known must, for its part, be affected. Indeed, based on this account, since being is known by the act of knowing, insofar as it is known, it is changed to that extent because it is affected, which we insist does not happen to the quiescent.

Theaetetus: Correct.

Stranger: But, by Zeus, what are we saying? Are we actually going to be persuaded so easily that change, life, soul and thought are absent from what altogether is, that it neither lives nor thinks, but abides unchanging, solemn and pure, devoid of intelligence?

249a

Theaetetus: No, stranger. That would be an awful proposition were we to accept it.

Stranger: But would we say that it has intelligence, but does not have life?

Theaetetus: How could we?

Stranger: But if we say that both of these are within it, shall we then deny that it has them in a soul?

Theaetetus: How else could it have them?

249b

Stranger: But if it actually has intelligence, life and soul, does it remain totally unchanging, although it has a soul?

Theaetetus: This all sounds unreasonable to me.

Stranger: And, of course, we must concede that change, and what is changed, both are.

Theaetetus: How could we deny it?

Stranger: It follows, therefore, Theaetetus, that if there is no change, there is no intelligence in anything, or about anything at all.

Theaetetus: Certainly.

249c

Stranger: And yet, if we concede instead that everything is moving and changing, by this argument too we shall be removing intelligence from things that are.

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: Do you think there could ever be sameness of characteristics or manner or relation, without rest?

Theaetetus: Not at all.

Stranger: But in the absence of these, can you see how there could be intelligence, or how it could ever come into being anywhere?

Theaetetus: Not in the least.

249d

Stranger: Well then, we must do battle, using every possible argument, against the man who would make strong assertions

about anything at all, having done away with knowledge, thought and intelligence.

Theaetetus: Definitely.

Stranger: Now, all these issues are necessarily, it seems, of the utmost importance to the philosopher, and because of these he must not accept that the universe is at rest, whether it is said to be one or to consist of many forms. Nor should he listen at all to those who say that 'what is' is changing everywhere. Instead, he should invoke the childish prayer, 'I want everything', and should say that 'the all' and 'what is' are a combination of both the unchanging and the changing.

Theaetetus: Very true.

249e

Stranger: Well then, is it likely that we have at last come to grips with 'what is' by this argument?

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: Oh dear, Theaetetus, perhaps not! I think that we are just about to appreciate the perplexity involved in this enquiry.

Theaetetus: How? Why have you said this?

Stranger: Bless you! Do you not realise that we are now in utter ignorance about this, though we seem to ourselves to be talking sense?

Theaetetus: Well, so it seems to me, but I do not quite understand how we got into this condition without noticing it.

250a

Stranger: Well, in agreeing with what has been said, consider carefully whether we may justifiably be open to the very questions which we ourselves put previously to those who say that the universe is heat and cold.

Theaetetus: What questions? Remind me.

Stranger: Yes, certainly. And I shall try to do this at any rate by questioning you, just as we questioned the others, so that we may also make some progress at the same time.

Theaetetus: Right.

Stranger: Very well then. Don't you say that motion and rest are completely opposite to one another?

Theaetetus: They must be.

250b

Stranger: And do you also say that in like manner they both are, and that each of them is?

Theaetetus: Yes, I do say that.

Stranger: And when you accept that they are, do you mean that both of them and each of them is moving?

Theaetetus: Not at all.

Stranger: Then, in saying that both of them are, are you indicating that they are both at rest?

Theaetetus: No, how could they be?

Stranger: So, are you proposing that being is some third thing in the soul besides these two, and having understood that both rest and motion are encompassed by this, do you look to their commonality of being, and thus make the statement that they both are?

250c

Theaetetus: Yes. It is quite likely that we do, in truth, have an intuition that 'what is' is some third entity, whenever we say that motion and rest are.

Stranger: So 'what is' is not the two together, motion and rest, but something different from them.

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Stranger: Then, based upon its own nature, 'what is' is neither at rest nor in motion.

Theaetetus: Hardly.

Stranger: Well then, where is there still left for someone's mind to turn who wishes to establish anything clear and certain about this for himself?

Theaetetus: Where indeed?

250d

Stranger: I do not think there is any easy option left, for if something is not moving, how can it not be at rest? Or if it is not at rest at all, then how can it not be moving? Yet 'what is' has just appeared before us, outside of both motion and rest. But is this possible?

Theaetetus: No, it is totally impossible.

Stranger: However, it would be right to recall something about these.

Theaetetus: What is it?

Stranger: That we ended up in utter perplexity when we were asked what precisely the phrase 'what is not' should be applied to. Do you remember?

Theaetetus: How could I forget?

250e

Stranger: And are we now in any less perplexity in relation to what is?

Theaetetus: Well, stranger, it seems to me that we are in even greater perplexity, if that is possible.

Stranger: Let's take it, then, that this is where our difficulty lies. However, since what is and what is not are equally involved in perplexity, there is now some hope. For as one of them becomes more dimly or clearly evident, the other will do the

same. And if we prove unable to discern either, we shall scrutinise the description of both at once, as appropriately as we can.

251a

Theaetetus: Very good.

Stranger: Then let's explain how it happens that we refer to the same thing by many names, depending on the occasion.

Theaetetus: What sort of thing do you mean? Give an example.

Stranger: You know that we speak of a man, calling him lots of different things, attributing colours to him, and also shapes, dimensions, excellences and vices. In all these cases, and numerous others, we are saying not only that he is a man, but also that he is good, and countless other things. And in other cases, by the same argument, we propose that each is one, and then refer to it as many, and so we describe it by many names.

251b

Theaetetus: What you say is true.

Stranger: Well, at any rate, I believe we have provided a feast for the young and for the old men whose learning came late in their lives. For it is easy for anyone to appreciate quite readily that it is impossible for the many to be one and also for one to be many, and indeed they delight in forbidding man from being called good, and they only allow good to be called good and man to be called man. Indeed, Theaetetus, I imagine you have often met those who take this sort of thing seriously. Sometimes older men who are amazed at such marvels, due to the poverty-stricken state of their intellect, actually believe that they have discovered the very repository of all wisdom.

251c

Theaetetus: They certainly do.

Stranger: Then, so that our discussion may be all inclusive, we should direct our questioning now to all those who have ever

discoursed on being in any way at all, and to those with whom we discussed this earlier.

Theaetetus: And the questions are?

Stranger: "Whether we may neither attach being to motion and rest, nor attach anything at all to anything else, and should we therefore propose, in our own discussions, that these are unmixed, and it is impossible for them to participate in one another? Or should we have grouped them all together as the same, in their capacity for communion with one another? Or can some have this capacity while others do not?" Well, Theaetetus, can we say which of these options they would choose?

251d

Theaetetus: I cannot answer these questions on their behalf at all.

Stranger: Then why don't you answer them one by one, and see what the consequences are in each case?

Theaetetus: A good suggestion.

Stranger: First, if you wish, let's propose that they say that nothing has any power of communion with anything else at all. In that case, movement and rest will have no share of being, will they?

Theaetetus: Not in that case.

Stranger: But will either of them be, if they have no communion with being?

Theaetetus: They will not.

251e

Stranger: Well, all parties have been instantly overthrown by this concession it seems, including the 'universe is motion' people, those who say it is one and at rest, and anyone who

maintains that things that are consist of forms which are always just the same as they are. Indeed, all of these people associate being with something, some by saying that the universe is actually movement, others by saying that it is actually rest.

Theaetetus: Quite so.

252a

Stranger: And, indeed, those who propose to combine all things at one time and to separate them at some other time, either by having unlimited things coming from one and returning to one, or else by dividing all things into finite elements and making combinations of these, regardless of whether they propose that this happens successively or continuously, these people would be talking nonsense in all cases, if, in fact, there is no comingling.

Theaetetus: Correct.

252b

Stranger: And what's more, the people who pursue this question, in the most ridiculous manner, are those who allow nothing to be referred to as different because it shares a different characteristic.

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: Well, presumably they are compelled to use 'to be' in relation to everything. They cannot help employing 'apart' and 'the others' and 'itself', and very many more expressions, and connecting them when they speak, and so they are refuting themselves. The enemy and future opponent is within themselves, as the saying goes, and they walk about carrying his voice inside them like the strange ventriloquist, Eurycles.¹⁴

252d

Theaetetus: The comparison you make is both accurate and true.

Stranger: Well then, should we concede to all things the capacity for intercommunion with one another?

Theaetetus: Even I would be able to do away with that suggestion.

Stranger: How?

Theaetetus: Well, movement itself would be totally at rest, while rest itself would, in turn, be moving if they were to come together with one another.

Stranger: And, presumably, it must be utterly impossible that movement be at rest, and rest in motion?

Theaetetus: It must be.

Stranger: Only the third option is left then.

Theaetetus: Yes.

252e

Stranger: Well, it must be some one of the following: either everything will mix together or nothing will, or some will and others will not.

Theaetetus: There are no other options.

Stranger: And yet the first two were found to be impossible.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: So anyone who wishes to give the right answer will select the last of the three.

Theaetetus: Exactly.

253a

Stranger: Now, since some things will do this and others will not, they would be behaving much like the letters of the alphabet, for some of them will not fit together with one another, while others will fit together.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: And the vowels are better at this than the other letters. They are like a bond running through them all so that it is impossible for one of the others to attach to anything else without at least one of the vowels.

Theaetetus: Certainly.

Stranger: Does everyone know what letters can combine with what, or is a skill required by someone who is to do this properly?

Theaetetus: There is a skill.

Stranger: What is it?

Theaetetus: Grammar.

253b

Stranger: And isn't it the same where high and low notes are concerned? Does the musical person have the skill to recognise which notes go together and which do not, while the unmusical person does not understand this?

Theaetetus: Yes, it is the same.

Stranger: And we shall find that similar distinctions between skill and lack of skill apply to other subjects.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: Yes. And since we have agreed that the kinds can also mix with one another in this same way, mustn't a man who is going to show correctly which of the kinds accord with one another or reject one another proceed through the arguments with some knowledge? And will he also need some knowledge to show whether there are certain kinds which pervade all the kinds and keep them together, so that they can be mixed together, and again, in the case of division, whether the causes of division are entirely different?

253d

Theaetetus: How could he do it without knowledge, perhaps even the supreme knowledge?

Stranger: Well now, Theaetetus, what are we going to call this knowledge? Or, by Zeus, have we stumbled unwittingly upon the knowledge belonging to free men? And is it possible that we have found first the philosopher, whilst looking for the sophist?

Theaetetus: What do you mean?

Stranger: This division on the basis of kinds, without thinking that the same form is a different form or that a different one is the same, should we not say that this belongs to dialectical knowledge?

Theaetetus: Yes, we should.

Stranger: Therefore, someone who can do this readily discerns one characteristic extending entirely through many things, each of which is separate and one; and many characteristics which are different from one another, encompassed externally by one characteristic; furthermore, one characteristic connected in one kind through multiplicities that are wholes; and many characteristics which are distinct and completely separate. This is knowing how to distinguish, kind by kind, which way they commune and which way they do not.

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

253e

Stranger: And I am sure that you will never grant this dialectical skill to anyone except a man who loves wisdom, purely and righteously.

Theaetetus: Indeed, how could one grant it to anyone else?

Stranger: It is in some such place as this that we shall find the philosopher, both now and hereafter, if we search for him. It is, indeed, difficult to see this person plainly, but the difficulty of

seeing the sophist is of a different sort from this.

Theaetetus: How?

254a

Stranger: Well, the sophist runs away into the darkness of non-being, attaching himself to this by practice, and he is hard to discern because of the darkness of the place. Is this so?

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Stranger: However the philosopher is always devoted, through reasoning, to the characteristic of what is. And he is also not at all easy to see because of the brightness of that region, as it is impossible for the eyes of the common soul to sustain the gaze that looks towards the divine.

Theaetetus: Yes, all this is no less likely to be so than what was said about the sophist.

254b

Stranger: Well, we shall consider the philosopher in more detail presently, if we so desire. But it is obvious, I presume, that we must not give up on the sophist until we can see him properly.

Theaetetus: Very good.

254c

Stranger: Indeed, we have actually agreed now that some of the kinds will combine with one another, while others will not, and some will combine with few, others with many, and also that some are all-pervasive and are allowed to combine with everything. So we should proceed to the next issue by considering the following question, not about all the forms, lest we get confused by the multiplicity, but selecting some of those which are said to be the most important. We should first ask what sort each is, and then what their power to commune with one another is. In this way, we shall at least understand something about being and non-being, as far as our current

method of enquiry allows, even if we cannot apprehend them with total clarity, and we may somehow be allowed to say that 'what is not', is actually non-being, and avoid reproach.

Theaetetus: Yes, we must do this.

254d

Stranger: Now, the most important kinds are those we have just mentioned – being itself, rest and motion.

Theaetetus: Very much so.

Stranger: And we also say that two of them do not mix with one another.

Theaetetus: They do not.

Stranger: And yet being mixes with both, for presumably both are.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: So there are these three.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: And of these, each of the two is different from the other, and the same as itself.

254e

Theaetetus: Quite so.

255a

Stranger: Well now, what precisely are the 'same' and the 'different' which we have just mentioned? Are they two additional kinds, apart from the first three, two kinds which must necessarily combine with the three, and should we investigate them as though there were five and not three? Or is this 'same' and 'different' something belonging to the other three, which we are referring to without noticing it?

Theaetetus: Perhaps.

Stranger: But of course, motion and rest are neither different nor the same.

Theaetetus: How so?

Stranger: Whatever we attribute to motion and rest jointly cannot itself be either of the two.

Theaetetus: Why is that?

255b

Stranger: Because motion would then be at rest, and rest would be moving. For the involvement of either of the two with both of them will compel the other one to change to the opposite of its own nature, since it is partaking of its opposite.

Theaetetus: Exactly.

Stranger: However, both partake of the same and the different.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: Therefore, we may not say that either motion or rest is the same or the different.

Theaetetus: No.

Stranger: Well then, should we think of 'what is' and 'the same' as one thing?

Theaetetus: Perhaps.

255c

Stranger: But if 'what is' and 'the same' do not signify anything different, then saying once more that motion and rest both are will amount to referring to them both as the same.

Theaetetus: Yes, but that is impossible.

Stranger: So it is impossible for 'the same' and 'what is' to be one.

Theaetetus: Quite.

Stranger: Well, should we propose that the same is a fourth form in addition to the other three?

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: Yes, but should we say that the different is a fifth? Or must we think of the different, and what is, as two names for one kind?

Theaetetus: Perhaps.

Stranger: But I think you concede that some things that are, are always spoken of just by themselves, while some are always spoken of in relation to others.

Theaetetus: So they are.

255d

Stranger: And different is always in relation to another. Is this so?

Theaetetus: Just so.

Stranger: But this would not be the case if what is and different were not utterly distinct. But if different, like what is, were to partake of both relations, some of the different things would sometimes be different, but not in relation to another. But now we find, simply, that whatever is different necessarily turns out to be the very thing it is, namely, different from something else.

Theaetetus: It is exactly as you say.

255e

Stranger: Then we must say that the nature of the different is a fifth form among these forms we are selecting.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: And we shall say that this pervades all the others, for each one is different from the others, not because of its own nature, but because of participation in the characteristic of different.

Theaetetus: Yes, precisely.

Stranger: Now, let us say the following about these five, taking them up one by one.

Theaetetus: What?

Stranger: First, that motion is completely different from rest. Is this so?

Theaetetus: It is so.

Stranger: So it is not rest.

Theaetetus: Not at all.

Stranger: And yet, because of participation in being, it is.

Theaetetus: It is.

256a

Stranger: Then again, motion is different from the same.

Theaetetus: I dare say.

Stranger: So it is not the same.

Theaetetus: No, it is not.

Stranger: And yet it is the same as itself, because everything partakes of the same.

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed.

Stranger: So we should accept that motion is the same and not the same, without making difficulties. For when we say it is the same and then not the same, we are not speaking in a similar manner. Rather, when we say it is the same, it is because of its participation in the same in relation to itself. And when we say it is not the same, it is because of its communion with different, a communion by which it is separated from the same and becomes not the same but different. So that it is correct, in turn, to say that it is not the same after all.

256b

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: Yes, and if motion itself were somehow to partake of rest, it would not be strange to say that motion was resting.

Theaetetus: And that is perfectly valid, provided we are going to accept that some of the kinds will mix with one another, and some will not.

Stranger: And, indeed, we arrived at a proof of this before now, establishing that this process is in accordance with nature.

Theaetetus: Of course.

256c

Stranger: Then let's say this once more. Motion is different from the different, just as it was other than the same and rest.

Theaetetus: Yes, it must be.

Stranger: So, in a sense then, it is not different and it is different, according to the current argument.

Theaetetus: True.

Stranger: Then, what about the next point? Shall we say that motion is different from three of the kinds but not from the fourth, though we have agreed that there are five items concerning which, and among which, we propose to conduct our enquiry?

Theaetetus: How could we? For we cannot accept that their number is less than what was shown a moment ago.

256d

Stranger: So, should we persist fearlessly in maintaining that motion is different from being?

Theaetetus: Yes, with no fear at all.

Stranger: Well then, it is clear that motion is actually 'non-being'. And yet it is, since in fact it partakes of being.

Theaetetus: Yes, that is perfectly clear.

256e

Stranger: So, of necessity, what is not is, both in the case of motion and all of the kinds, for in all cases the nature of the different, by rendering each different from what is, makes it what is not. And, indeed, in this way, we are right to say, on the same basis, that all of them are not, and again, because they partake of being, that they are and have being.

Theaetetus: Very likely.

Stranger: So, in the case of each of the forms, 'what is' is many, and 'what is not' is unlimited in multiplicity.

Theaetetus: So it seems.

257a

Stranger: Well then, we must also say that what is, itself, is different from the others.

Theaetetus: We must.

Stranger: And we also found that as many as the others are, to that extent what is, is not. For on the one hand, not being those others it is itself one, and furthermore, it is not, in respect of number, those unlimited others.

Theaetetus: Quite so.

Stranger: Now, we should not make difficulties over these either since the nature of the kinds involves communion with one another. But if anyone does not accept this, he must prevail over our previous arguments and then take on their consequences.

Theaetetus: What you propose is very fair.

257b

Stranger: Well, let us note the following.

Theaetetus: What?

Stranger: When we speak of 'what is not', it seems we are not speaking of something opposite to 'what is', but only of something different.

Theaetetus: In what way?

Stranger: For example, when we say that something is 'not large', are we indicating by this phrase that it is small rather than equal? Is that how it seems to you?

Theaetetus: How could it?

257c

Stranger: So, whenever it is said that a negative signifies an opposite, we shall not accept that. We shall only go so far as to say that prefixing 'not' or 'non' indicates something else apart from the words which follow, or rather, apart from the things to which the words uttered after the negatives may refer.

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

Stranger: Let's think this through as follows, if you agree.

Theaetetus: In what way?

Stranger: It seems to me that the nature of different is broken up in the same way that knowledge is.

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: Well, presumably knowledge is one, and so is the nature of different, but each portion of knowledge applicable to something in particular has been separated off and given its own particular title. That's why so many skills and branches of knowledge are referred to.

257d

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: And although the nature of different is one, the same thing happens to the parts.

Theaetetus: Very likely, but how should we describe it?

Stranger: Is there some part of different which contrasts with beauty?

Theaetetus: There is.

Stranger: Now should we say that this is nameless, or does it have a title of its own?

Theaetetus: It has. For each time we mention 'non-beauty', this is different from the nature of beauty, and from nothing else.

257e

Stranger: Come now, tell me this.

Theaetetus: What?

Stranger: On this basis, has non-beauty turned out to be some distinct part of a single kind among things that are, and does it, in turn, stand in contrast to another kind among things that are?

Theaetetus: It does.

Stranger: Then it seems non-beauty turns out to be a contrast of 'what is' with 'what is'.

Theaetetus: Quite right.

Stranger: Well then, based on this account, is beauty more included among things that are, and non-beauty less so?

Theaetetus: It is not.

258a

Stranger: So, should we say, on the same basis, that there is non-largeness and largeness itself?

Theaetetus: On the same basis.

Stranger: And should we therefore place non-justice in the same relation towards justice, in that one is no more than the other is?

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: Well, we shall also describe the others in the same way. Since, in fact, the nature of different has been shown to be included among things that are, and since it is, we must necessarily propose that the parts of it are also things that are, no less.

Theaetetus: Yes, we must.

258b

Stranger: Therefore, it seems, when part of the nature of different, and part of the nature of 'what is' are set against one another, the contrast is no less being than what is, itself, if such a statement is legitimate, and this contrast is not indicating the opposite of 'what is', but only something different from that.

Theaetetus: Yes, that is very clear.

Stranger: So, what should we call this?

Theaetetus: Obviously it is 'what is not', the very thing we were seeking because of the sophist.

258c

Stranger: And does it, as you say, have no less being than anything else? And should we now declare boldly that 'what is not' certainly is, and has its own nature? And just as largeness was large and beauty was beautiful, and the same applied to non-largeness and non-beauty, should we say on the same basis that 'what is not' was and is 'what is not', a single form counted among the many things that are? Do we still have any doubt about this, Theaetetus?

Theaetetus: Not at all.

258d

Stranger: Now, do you realise that we have shown little regard for Parmenides' prohibition?

Theaetetus: In what way?

Stranger: In our previous enquiry, we have forged ahead in our search, and presented the man with something he forbade us to consider.

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: Well, he says, *"For never shall this be proved that things that are not, are, but do thou, in thine enquiry, hold back thy thought from this way."*

258e

Theaetetus: Yes, that is what he says.

Stranger: Yet we have shown not only that things that are not, are. We have also revealed the form upon which 'what is not' happens to be based. In fact, having shown that the nature of different is, and is divided up among all things that are in relation to one another, we have dared to maintain that each part of different that contrasts with what is, is really 'what is not'.

259a

Theaetetus: Yes, stranger, and the statements we have made seem to me to be entirely true.

Stranger: Then let no one say that we have dared to maintain that 'what is not' is the opposite of 'what is'. For we long since said farewell to talk of opposite of 'what is', whether there is or is not such a thing, and whether it has an account or is utterly devoid of one. Now, in relation to 'what is not' which we have proposed to be, let someone refute us, and either persuade us that we have not formulated it correctly, or, until he is able to refute it, he must say what we say, that the kinds combine with one another, and 'what is' and the different go through them

all, and through one another, and the different, by partaking of 'what is', is, because of that participation, although it is not what it partakes of, but is different. And being different from 'what is', clearly it must be possible for it to be 'what is not'. And, in turn, 'what is', by partaking of the different, will be other from the other kinds, and since it is different from all of them, it is not each of them, nor all of them together except for itself. Consequently, 'what is' undoubtedly is not, in countless instances, and the others, individually and collectively, are in many cases, but are not in many cases.

259c

Theaetetus: True.

Stranger: And one who is at a loss to believe these contradictions must consider these matters for himself and offer a better account than we have just given. But if he has taken hold of something difficult, and finds pleasure now in dragging the arguments to one extreme and now to another, his exertions are not worth taking very seriously, as our current arguments would suggest. For this is neither inventive nor difficult to discover. But what is difficult, and beautiful, is something else.

Theaetetus: What is it?

259d

Stranger: What we said before, allowing such considerations as ineffective; to be able to follow what is said, refuting it stage by stage; if anyone proposes that the different is somehow the same, or the same different, in the very respect in which, and the very way that he says one experiences the other. But by saying that the same is somehow different, and the different is the same, and the great is small, and the like is unlike, and to derive pleasure from constantly bringing forward such oppositions in arguments, this is no real refutation. Indeed, it is obvious that someone who has just appeared on the scene is

grasping at a beginning understanding of things that are.

259e

Theaetetus: Yes, that is so.

Stranger: Well now, my friend, the attempt to separate everything from everything else is, in general, an inappropriate response and is, in fact, the activity of someone who is uneducated and unphilosophical.

Theaetetus: Why is that?

Stranger: Yes, this very approach of dissociating each thing from everything else is the total disappearance of all argument. Indeed, the interweaving of forms with one another is the basis from which our discourse arises.

260a

Theaetetus: True.

Stranger: So, consider the timely battle which we waged just now against people like that, and how we have compelled them to allow one to mix with another.

Theaetetus: To what end?

Stranger: So that argument may continue to exist for us. For we would have been deprived of this if we had also deprived ourselves of the interweaving of forms with one another. Indeed, our argument has somehow arisen for us from the interweaving of forms with one another.

260b

Theaetetus: True.

Stranger: Now since we have got rid of this difficulty, but at the same time agreed that being is to be associated with non-being, perhaps we should now try to consider speech.

Theaetetus: How so?

Stranger: If 'what is not' has nothing to do with speech, all argument is necessarily false, while in fact it has been associated with it, and so there is false speech, and false thinking.

Theaetetus: Just so.

Stranger: But if there is falsity, deception arises.

Theaetetus: Yes.

260c

Stranger: And if there is deception, everything is necessarily full of images, likenesses and appearances.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: And we said that the sophist took refuge in some such place, but he completely denied that there is falsity at all. For he said that 'what is not' could not be thought or stated, since 'what is not' does not partake of being in any way.

Theaetetus: Just so.

Stranger: And now it has appeared that 'what is not' partakes of being, so he probably will not contest the matter further on that basis. Yet he might say that some of the forms partake of 'what is not', while others do not, and speech and opinion are among those which do not. So in opting again for the contention that the skills of image-making and appearance-making, in which we said he was contained, do not exist at all, he might also argue that there is no false opinion or speech. For opinion and speech have no communion with 'what is not'. And in the absence of this association, there is no possibility of any falsity. That's why we must first investigate speech, opinion and appearance, to see precisely what they are, so that, having seen them, we shall recognise their communion with 'what is not', and having recognised this, we shall prove that there is falsity, and having proved this, we shall imprison

the sophist there, if we can keep our hold of him, and if we cannot, we shall release him and search in another kind.

261a

Theaetetus: Stranger, this expression about the sophist at the outset did indeed appear to be true, that this kind is hard to hunt. For he turns out to be replete with stratagems, and whenever he employs them, he must be vanquished before he can be caught. But now, although he has barely been overcome, he is already objecting that 'what is not', is not. For he is a wonder.

Stranger: Well, my friend, it is the man with greater experience who will be best able to give the more accurate account, since whoever has been confounded for the longest time, often, is more vexed.

261b

Theaetetus: A good point.

Stranger: Well, let's continue with the present argument and not get vexed.

Theaetetus: Why should we?

Stranger: Indeed, what comes first, in my view, is the question of speech, just as it was earlier in the case of the forms. For this is what we need to consider now: is 'what is not' associated with this too, or is speech entirely true, with no falsity ever arising in this?

Theaetetus: Yes, this is what we should consider.

261c

Stranger: Come now, since we said as much in relation to the forms and letters of the alphabet, let's consider names again in the same way.

Theaetetus: Yes, but what should we look for in them?

Stranger: Whether they all combine with one another, none of them combine, or some can do so, while others cannot.

Theaetetus: Well, this is clear in any case: that some can and some cannot.

Stranger: Perhaps you mean the following: that any words which are uttered in succession and indicate something are combined, while those which are not significant when uttered in succession are not combined.

261d

Theaetetus: What you say? Why?

Stranger: I imagined that you were making the same response that I have actually had in mind. Indeed, we recognise two kinds of vocal expressions about being.

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: One is referred to as a name, and the other as a verb.

Theaetetus: Tell me what each of these is.

261e

Stranger: The expression that applies to actions, we presumably refer to as a verb.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: While the vocal label applicable to those who perform such actions is a name.

Theaetetus: Quite so.

Stranger: Well, no statement can ever arise from a string of names that are uttered in succession, or even of verbs separated from names.

Theaetetus: I do not understand.

262a

Stranger: Yes, it was clear when you responded just now that what I am saying is different. For my point was that the sequence does not constitute a statement.

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: Take for instance "walks, runs, sleeps", and the other verbs which signify actions: even if someone were to recite them all in turn, that would not constitute any statement at all.

Theaetetus: Why not?

Stranger: So again, when "lion, stag, horse" are uttered, and any other names of those who perform actions, this sequence does not constitute a statement either. Indeed, neither in the first case nor in this one are the spoken words associated with any action, or in actuality, of one who acts or does not act. Nor will it ever do so, until someone mixes verbs with names. And as soon as he does so, the joining together produces a statement, the first and the smallest of statements, I dare say.

262c

Theaetetus: What do you mean by this?

Stranger: Whenever someone says, "a man understands", do you say that this is the shortest and the first statement?

Theaetetus: I do.

Stranger: Indeed, it now provides some information about what is, becomes, has become or is to become, and not just naming, but enacting something by combining verbs with names. That is why we have said that it has spoken, and not merely named. And what is more, this combination is the very thing to which we attached the title 'speech'.

Theaetetus: Correct.

262d

Stranger: Now, just as some things fit together with one another, while others do not, the same applies to vocal expressions, some of which do not fit together, while those that do fit together produce statements.

Theaetetus: Just so.

Stranger: But there is still one further consideration.

Theaetetus: What?

Stranger: Whenever there is a statement, it must be a statement about something. Indeed, a statement about nothing is impossible.

Theaetetus: Just so.

Stranger: And it must, of course, also have a particular quality.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: So now, let's take note of ourselves.

Theaetetus: Yes, we should.

262e

Stranger: Then I shall make a statement to you, putting things and actions together by means of a name and a verb. You should indicate to me what the statement is about.

Theaetetus: Yes, just as far as I can.

Stranger: "Theaetetus is sitting." Surely that is not a long statement?

Theaetetus: No, it has just the right measure.

Stranger: Now it is your turn to say what it is about, and to whom it refers.

Theaetetus: Quite clear that it is about me, and refers to me.

263a

Stranger: Then what about this one?

Theaetetus: What?

Stranger: "Theaetetus, with whom I am conversing right now, is flying."

Theaetetus: No one could deny that this too is mine, and refers to me.

Stranger: And we maintain that each of these is necessarily of some quality.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: Now, what quality should we say each of these has?

Theaetetus: One is false, the other true.

Stranger: And the true one indicates the things that are, as they are, in your case.

263b

Theaetetus: Just so.

Stranger: While the false one indicates things that are different from things that are.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: Then it speaks of things that are not, as if they are.

Theaetetus: Just so.

Stranger: But it speaks of things that are, though they are different from things that are about you. For we have said, you remember, that in the case of each, there are many things that are, and also many that are not.

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

263c

Stranger: Now, the second statement I made about you, in the first place, based on the way we have defined statement, must necessarily be one of the shortest.

Theaetetus: Well, that's how it was agreed just now anyway.

Stranger: And, then, in turn, the statement must be about someone.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: And if it is not about you, surely it is not about anyone else.

Theaetetus: Indeed not.

Stranger: And it would not even be a statement at all if it were about no one. For we showed that it was impossible for there to be a statement which is a statement about nothing.

Theaetetus: Quite right.

263d

Stranger: Then, in this statement about you, when different things are stated as the same and 'what is not' as 'what is', it appears that the combination of verbs with names absolutely turns out to be a real and true false statement.

Theaetetus: Very true.

Stranger: Now, what about thought, opinion and appearance? Isn't it already clear that all of these become both true and false in our souls?

Theaetetus: How?

263e

Stranger: You will recognise this more easily if you first realise what each of these is, and how each differs from one another.

Theaetetus: Just tell me.

Stranger: Now, are not thought and speech the same, except that the silent dialogue of the soul with itself has been given the name 'thought'?

Theaetetus: Quite so.

Stranger: And the flow from the soul to the mouth which is vocally expressed has been given the name 'speech'.

Theaetetus: True.

264a

Stranger: And what's more, we know that the following arises in speech.

Theaetetus: What is that?

Stranger: Affirmation and denial.

Theaetetus: Yes, we know that.

Stranger: So when this happens in the soul through thought, in silence, can you call it anything other than opinion?

Theaetetus: What else?

Stranger: What about this? Whenever such an experience arises in someone, not through himself but on account of perception, is there another appropriate name for this experience, except 'appearance'?

Theaetetus: There is not.

264b

Stranger: Then, since speech turned out to be both true and false, and we showed that thought is the discourse of the soul with itself; and that opinion is the conclusion of thought; and what we mean by 'it appears' is a combination of perception and opinion; isn't it the case that any of these must be false sometimes since they are kindred to speech?

Theaetetus: Of course.

264c

Stranger: Then do you appreciate that there has been an earlier discovery of false opinion and speech than was expected, when we feared that we were taking on an entirely impossible task by setting out in search of it?

Theaetetus: I do.

Stranger: Then we should not become disheartened by what remains. For since these have become apparent, we should recall the previous divisions on the basis of forms.

Theaetetus: Which ones?

Stranger: Well, we divided image-making into two forms: likeness-making and appearance-making.

Theaetetus: Yes.

264d

Stranger: And we said that we were perplexed about which of these we would place the sophist in.

Theaetetus: So we did.

Stranger: And while we were unsure about this, even greater confusion arose for us, with the appearance of the argument which would dispute these, and maintain that there is no such thing as a likeness, image or appearance, since in no case at all is there any falsity, either in any way or at any time.

Theaetetus: What you say is true.

Stranger: But now, since false speech and false opinion have appeared, it is possible for there to be imitations of things that are, and from this disposition, a skill in deception arises.

264e

Theaetetus: Yes, it is possible.

Stranger: And, indeed, we agreed earlier that the sophist was located in one of the divisions mentioned.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: Then let's try again, take the proposed kind and divide it in two, all the while proceeding to the right-hand part of what is being divided, holding on to the communion of the

sophist, until we strip away whatever is common to the others, leaving only his own particular nature, which we shall display, first to ourselves, and then to those who are by nature most kindred to such a method.

265a

Theaetetus: Right.

Stranger: Now, didn't we begin by dividing skill at that time into productive and acquisitive?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: And the sophist appeared to us in the acquisitive parts of hunting, contest, retailing, and certain kinds of that sort.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

265b

Stranger: But now, since he has been included under the skill of imitation, it is clear that we should first divide the productive skill in two. For presumably the skill of imitation is some kind of making, except that we shall say that it makes images, but not actual things. Is this so?

Theaetetus: Yes, entirely so.

Stranger: Now, in the first place, let there be two parts of the productive skill.

Theaetetus: What are they?

Stranger: The divine and the human.

Theaetetus: I do not yet understand.

Stranger: If you remember what was said at the start, we said that all production is the power which gives rise to whatever was not, previously.

Theaetetus: We remember.

265c

Stranger: Now, with regard to all mortal animals, and as for all things that grow on earth from seeds and roots, and the lifeless bodies, with or without souls, that are formed within the earth: shall we say that some other than god is the producer who gives rise to them from non-being? Or are we to say what most people say and accept?

Theaetetus: What?

Stranger: That nature gives rise to them through some spontaneous cause that produces them without intelligence. Or are they produced with reasoning and divine knowledge that comes from god?

265d

Theaetetus: I myself, perhaps due to my age, often shift my views from one of these positions to the other. However, looking at you now, and noticing that you think that these things have arisen through divine agency, I myself also believe this is the case.

Stranger: Good, Theaetetus, and if we thought that you were one of those people who would think differently in the future, we would now try, by means of an argument involving compelling persuasiveness, to make you agree. But since I am aware of your nature and recognise that even without our arguments, it is moving on by itself in the direction you say it is now inclined, I shall let the matter rest, for it would be a waste of time. Instead, let me propose that what are said to be the products of nature are produced by divine skill, while products that come from these products and are produced by humans, are produced by human skill. And, based on this account, there are two kinds of productive skill, the human and the divine.

265e

Theaetetus: Right.

Stranger: Now, since there are two of these, divide each of them again in two.

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: As though you were dividing the whole production skill widthwise just now, divide it lengthwise this time.

Theaetetus: Take it as done.

266a

Stranger: In this way, there are now four parts in total: the two human parts on our side, and the two divine parts on the side of the gods.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: And, in turn, when divided in the other way, one part of each section is itself a making, while what remains in both cases is most accurately referred to as an image-making, and so production becomes two-fold again.

Theaetetus: Tell me again how this division goes.

266b

Stranger: Well, presumably we ourselves, and the other animals, and the things from which natural objects come – fire, water and their kindred – we know that all of these are produced by the god, who has made each of them. Is this so?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: Following each of these, there are images, not the things themselves, and they have also come about through divine ingenuity.

Theaetetus: What are they?

Stranger: The phantoms that appear in dreams, and those that arise of their own accord during the day, such as a shadow when darkness occurs in firelight, and the doubles produced when one's own light, falling on bright and smooth surfaces,

encounters the light from objects facing it, gives rise to an appearance opposite to the usual sight.

266c

Theaetetus: These two are, indeed, products of divine making: the actual object and the image which follows in each case.

Stranger: What about our skill? Won't we say that on the one hand it produces the house itself by the skill of building, while on the other, by the skill of painting, it produces another, which is some sort of human-made dream for those who are awake.

Theaetetus: Just so.

Stranger: Then, on the same basis, all the other products of our productive activity also come in twos according to our account: there is the thing itself produced by the making skill, and the image produced by the image-making skill.

266d

Theaetetus: I understand better now. And I now propose that there are two twofold productive skills: the divine and the human, based on one division, and the other yields the things themselves and a sort of likeness of these.

Stranger: Now let's recall that we said there are two forms of image-making: one is likeness-making, while the other is appearance-making, provided false had been shown to be truly false, and to belong by nature, among things that are.

Theaetetus: Yes, it was so.

Stranger: And this has appeared, and so on this basis shall we now propose, without dispute, that there are two forms?

Theaetetus: Yes.

266e

Stranger: Then let's divide the appearance-making, in turn, in two.

Theaetetus: How?

Stranger: One is the appearance produced by instruments, while the other is when the maker of the appearance presents himself as the instrument.

Theaetetus: What do you mean?

Stranger: Whenever someone uses his own body or voice to make something appear like your body or your voice, I think this part of appearance-making is, in general, called imitation.

Theaetetus: Yes.

267a

Stranger: Let us call this part imitation, and set it aside, and we shall be lazy and entrust the entire remainder to someone else, to make this one into one form and assign it an appropriate name.

Theaetetus: Yes, that's how we should distinguish them and pass on the other.

Stranger: And yet, Theaetetus, it is appropriate to think of this also as two-fold. Now consider the reason why.

Theaetetus: Tell me.

Stranger: Of those who imitate, some do so with knowledge of what they imitate, others without knowledge of it. And what distinction shall we make that is greater than that between knowledge and ignorance?

Theaetetus: None.

267b

Stranger: Now, the imitation we just mentioned belonged to those who know. For someone who knows you and your character would imitate you.

Theaetetus: Of course.

Stranger: But what about the appearance of justice and excellence in general? Don't many, who are ignorant of these but somehow have some opinion about them, give the appearance of inhabiting them by being eager to imitate what they themselves think, in word and deed, as much as possible?

Theaetetus: Yes, there are very many indeed.

Stranger: So, do they all fail in seeming to be just, although they are not at all? Or is the opposite the case?

Theaetetus: Quite the opposite.

267c

Stranger: I think then, we should say that this person is an imitator who is different from the other, the ignorant one from the one who knows.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Stranger: Now, where should we look for an appropriate name for each of them? Or is it obvious that this is somehow difficult, because there was some long-standing ignorance among the men of old when it came to dividing the kinds into forms, so that no one ever even bothered to make any division, and so it must be the case that names are not very abundant. However, even if it is somewhat rash to do so, let us, for the sake of the distinction, call the imitation based upon opinion, opinionative imitation, while the imitation based on knowledge is a kind of knowledgeable imitation.

Theaetetus: Let it be so.

267d

Stranger: Well, we should use the former, for the sophist did not belong with those who know, but with those who imitate.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: Then let's examine this opinionative imitator, just like a piece of iron, to see whether he is sound or whether there is still some flaw in him.

Theaetetus: We should examine him.

Stranger: Indeed, there is a really very significant flaw. For one of them is naive, thinking that he knows the matters about which he holds opinions, while the disposition of the other has had a great deal of involvement in arguments, and his very disposition gives rise to misgivings and fears that he does not know what he pretends to know in the presence of others.

267e

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly. There are indeed both kinds you describe.

Stranger: So, should we propose that one is a simple imitator while the other is an ironical imitator?

Theaetetus: That's likely.

Stranger: And should we, in turn, say that the form of this fellow is one, or two?

Theaetetus: Consider it yourself.

Stranger: I am considering it, and there appear, to a great extent, to be two. One I see, who is able to dissemble openly in lengthy speeches before large numbers, while the other does this in private, in short discourses, and forces the person who is conversing with him to contradict himself.

268a

Theaetetus: What you say is perfectly correct.

Stranger: Now, who should we propose is the more long-winded type? Is he a statesman or a popular orator?

Theaetetus: A popular orator.

Stranger: And what shall we call the other? A wise person, or a sophist?

Theaetetus: A wise person is impossible, since we proposed that he was ignorant, but since he is an imitator of a wise person, it is clear that he will have a name derived from his, and now I am almost in a position to recognise that we must really and truly refer to this person as the man who is sophist in every sense.

268b

Stranger: Then shall we put together his name, as we did before, weaving it together from end to beginning?

Theaetetus: Quite so.

Stranger: Now, the contradiction-making, ironical part of opinionative imitation belongs to the appearance-making kind, which is part of image-making and is marked off as the human, not the divine, part of production in the realm of word-making and wonder-working. So, anyone who says that the true sophist is "of that lineage and blood"¹⁵ will, it seems, speak the absolute truth.

268d

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

NOTES

1. A reference to the conversation in the Theaetetus, which concluded the previous day. At the end of that dialogue (Theaetetus 210d), Socrates arranged to meet Theaetetus and Theodorus again on the following morning.
2. Elea was a Greek colony in southern Italy, home to the philosophers Parmenides and Zeno, whose teachings emphasised the unity and unchangeability of being. The Eleatic Stranger is presented as a follower of this philosophical tradition.
3. A loose reference to Homer, *Odyssey* ix.270–271, where the god Zeus is described as the protector of strangers and suppliants who watches over human affairs.
4. A reference to Homer, *Odyssey* xvii.485–487, where gods in the likeness of strangers from afar are said to wander the cities of men, observing their behaviour.
5. A reference to Plato's dialogue *Parmenides*, in which the young Socrates engages in conversation with the elderly Parmenides and his associate Zeno.
6. The Greek word 'sophistes' is derived from 'sophos' (wise or clever). The stranger here plays on the etymology, observing that the sophist's name implies a wisdom which he does not in fact possess.
7. 'The Great King' was the standard Greek term for the King of Persia, ruler of the vast Persian Empire and traditionally regarded as the most powerful and wealthy man in the known world.
8. Protagoras of Abdera (c. 490–420 BCE) was one of the most famous of the early sophists. He is the principal figure in Plato's dialogue *Protagoras*, and his views on knowledge and perception are discussed extensively in the *Theaetetus*.
9. Parmenides, Fragment 7, lines 1–2. This same passage is quoted again by the Stranger at 258d as the 'paternal maxim' which they must refute.
10. A reference back to the paternal maxim of Parmenides quoted at 237a, which forbids the proposition that 'things that are not, are'.
11. The 'Ionian Muses' is taken to refer to Heraclitus of Ephesus, and the 'Sicilian Muses' to Empedocles of Acragas. Empedocles maintained that the cosmos was governed by the alternating forces of Love (combining) and Strife (separating).

12. A reference to Heraclitus, Fragment 51, expressing the doctrine that opposites are simultaneously in tension and harmony – combining even as they separate.
13. A reference to the mythical battle between the Olympian gods and the Giants, in which the Giants attempted to overthrow the gods by piling mountains upon one another to scale heaven. The story is recounted in Hesiod's *Theogony* 675–715 and elsewhere.
14. Eurycles was a famous Athenian ventriloquist and soothsayer who appeared to have a voice speaking from within his belly. Reference is made to him in Aristophanes, *Wasps* 1017–1020.
15. A formulaic Homeric phrase used when concluding a genealogy or lineage. The Stranger is using it ironically to mark the completion of the sophist's pedigree of definitions. Compare *Iliad* 6.211.

Statesman

ΠΟΛΙΤΙΚΟΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

THEODORUS of Cyrene, geometer

STRANGER from Elis in Italy

YOUNG SOCRATES of Athens

scene: in the Athenian gymnasium where the Theaetetus was set

257a

Socrates: Well, Theodorus, I owe you a great debt of gratitude for the acquaintance of Theaetetus, and of the stranger too.

Theodorus: And yet, Socrates, you will soon be three times more grateful once they have completed the statesman for you, and the philosopher too.

Socrates: What is this, Theodorus? Are we to say that we have heard our supreme reasoner and geometrician expressing the matter in this way?

257b

Theodorus: In what way, Socrates?

Socrates: By assigning equal worth to each of the men when they stand so far apart in value that they are completely out of the proportion that your skill deals with.

Theodorus: By our god Ammon,¹ Socrates, you have rebuked me nicely, and with justification, for the error in the calculations, and you demonstrated your excellent memory in the process. I'll get back to you on these issues some other time. As for you, stranger, you should never tire of gratifying us, and whether you prefer to take the man who is a statesman or the one who is a philosopher first, make your selection and go through it in detail.

257c

Stranger: That's what we should do, Theodorus, since once we have taken them on we should not give up until we have

brought them to a conclusion. However, what should I do about Theaetetus here?

Theodorus: In what sense?

Stranger: Should we rest him for a while and substitute his training companion, this young Socrates? What would you advise?

Theodorus: Make the change you just suggested, for they are both young and will bear all the exertion more readily if they are rested.

257d

Socrates: And, indeed, stranger, they would both seem to have a certain kinship with me. In one case you claim that he looks similar to me based on the nature of his face, while in the other case the fact that he is addressed by the same name provides some relationship. Of course, we should always be eager to get to know our kindred through discourse. So, I myself had dealings with Theaetetus in discussion yesterday, and I have now heard him answering questions too.² However, in the case of Socrates, I have done neither. This fellow should be tested too, so let him respond to you now, and to me on some other occasion.

258a

Stranger: So be it. Well, Socrates, are you listening to Socrates?

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: And do you agree with what he is proposing?

Young Socrates: Very much so.

Stranger: It appears there is no impediment on your side, and there should probably be even less on my side. Anyway, after the sophist, it is necessary in my view that the two of us seek out the man who is a statesman. So tell me, should we place him in the rank of those who are knowledgeable, or not?

Young Socrates: As you suggest.

258b

Stranger: In that case, should we divide knowledge just as we did when we investigated the previous personage?³

Young Socrates: Perhaps so.

Stranger: So be it. Well, Socrates, I think I see a division, although it is not on the same basis.

Young Socrates: What then?

Stranger: It is on a different basis.

Young Socrates: Quite likely.

Stranger: So, where may one discover the statesman-like path? For it is necessary to discover it and, having set it apart from the others, to impose one character upon it, and by assigning one distinctive form to the other branches, make this soul of ours regard all knowledge as being of two forms.

Young Socrates: This is now turning out to be a task for you, stranger, rather than for me.

Stranger: And yet it should be yours too, Socrates, once it has become plain to us.

Young Socrates: Well expressed.

258c

Stranger: Now, aren't arithmetic, and certain other skills akin to it, devoid of activity, as they simply provide knowing?

Young Socrates: This is the case.

Stranger: However, those concerned with carpentry and all sorts of manual labour have acquired their knowledge as if it were naturally inherent in the actions, and they use it to bring to completion the objects they generate, things that did not previously exist.

Young Socrates: What of it?

Stranger: Well, all knowledge may be subdivided in this way, by designating one part as involving action, and the other as only cognitive.

258d

Young Socrates: I grant that these two kinds belong to a single whole – knowledge.

Stranger: Now, shall we designate the statesman, the king, the master, and even the estate manager, as one, when we are referring to them all, or should we declare that the skills are just as many as the names that are spoken? But it is better for you to follow my lead here.

Young Socrates: In what way?

Stranger: As follows. If someone is competent to advise one of our public physicians, he himself being a private citizen, wouldn't it be necessary to refer to him by the name of the same skill as the person he is advising?

Young Socrates: Yes.

259a

Stranger: What about this? Shouldn't we say that a person who is a skilled adviser to a man who is exercising kingship over a country, being himself a private citizen, possesses the knowledge that the ruler himself should have acquired?

Young Socrates: We should say so.

259b

Stranger: But, of course, the skill of a true king is kingship.

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: And won't someone who has acquired this skill, whether he happens to be a ruler or a private citizen, be correctly referred to as kingly, in any case, on the basis of the

skill itself?

Young Socrates: And it is right to do so.

Stranger: Therefore, should we put all these things together as one and the same, statesmanship and the statesman and kingship and the king?

Young Socrates: We clearly should.

Stranger: And, indeed, estate manager and a master are the same?

Young Socrates: Of course.

Stranger: What about this? Surely there isn't any difference between an impressively large household and a substantial but a small city when it comes to rulership.

Young Socrates: None.

259c

Stranger: And so, on the matter we were considering, it is evident that one knowledge applies to them all. And whether someone designates it as kingship or statesmanship or estate management, we should not argue with him.

Young Socrates: No, why would we?

Stranger: But this much is obvious anyway, that in order to hold power, any king is able to do very little by means of his hands, or his body as a whole, in comparison with the intelligence and force of his soul.

Young Socrates: Obviously.

259d

Stranger: Well, do you want us to assert that a king has more affinity with cognitive knowledge rather than with knowledge that involves manual skill, and is on the whole active?

Young Socrates: Of course.

Stranger: In that case, shall we place all these together into the same, as one – statesmanship and the statesman, kingship and the kingly person?

Young Socrates: Obviously.

Stranger: Wouldn't we be proceeding in an orderly manner if we were to make a division in the cognitive knowledge next?

Young Socrates: Very much so.

Stranger: Then apply your mind, in case we can discern some natural division in it.

Young Socrates: What sort is it? Tell me.

259e

Stranger: As follows. We agree, I presume, that there is a skill of calculation?

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: In my view, it belongs entirely among the cognitive skills.

Young Socrates: How could it not?

Stranger: Now, once calculation has cognised the difference between the numbers, surely we would not assign it any other function over and above judging what it has cognised?

Young Socrates: No, why would we?

Stranger: And, indeed, any architect supervises workers but does not himself behave as a worker.

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: Providing, I presume, the cognitive aspect but not the manual labour.

Young Socrates: Quite so.

260a

Stranger: Then he may rightly be said to partake of the cognitive knowledge.

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: Yes, but in my view it belongs to this man, once he has made a judgement, neither to conclude the matter nor take his leave, in the way that the man who calculated took his leave, but to assign what's appropriate to each of the workers until such time as they have completed the assigned task.

Young Socrates: And rightly so.

260b

Stranger: Therefore, all such branches of knowledge are cognitive, and so are any that accompany calculation, yet these two kinds differ from one another when it comes to judging and directing.

Young Socrates: Apparently.

Stranger: Now, if we were to divide cognitive knowledge, referring to one part as directive and the other as judgemental, would we say it had been divided appropriately?

Young Socrates: Yes, in my view anyway.

Stranger: Now those who are engaged in a common task should be content if they themselves are like-minded.

Young Socrates: They should.

Stranger: Then as long as we are sharing a task, we should bid farewell to the viewpoints of anyone else.

Young Socrates: Of course.

260c

Stranger: Come on then, among which of these two skills should we include the kingly person? Is it among the judgemental, just like a spectator, or does he belong more to the directive skill insofar as he is exercising mastery? Shall we place

him there?

Young Socrates: More in the second, of course.

Stranger: Then we should see once more whether the directive skill divides in any way. Indeed, it seems to me that it does so as follows. Just as the skill of retailers is distinguished from the skill of those who sell their own produce, so too is the kingly class, seemingly, set apart from the class of public messengers.

Young Socrates: How so?

260d

Stranger: The retailers first receive products that are not their own, and then sell once more what had previously been sold to them.

Young Socrates: They certainly do.

Stranger: So too, messengers take other people's ideas as directions, and then direct others once more with the directions imparted to them.

Young Socrates: Very true.

Stranger: What now? Shall we mix together kingship, interpretation, instructing rowers, prophecy, imparting messages, and various other skills related to these, as if they were the same, because they all involve giving directions? Or, since we devised a likeness just now, would you like to devise a name, in an analogous manner, since the class of those who are 'own-directing' is effectively devoid of a name? We could then distinguish these activities in this way, placing the class of the kings with the 'own-directing' skill, paying no regard to all the rest, and allowing someone else to assign them a name, since our method is concerned with the ruler and not with his opposite.

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

260e

Stranger: Therefore, since this has been set apart from the rest in a measured way, defined by the contrast between otherness and kingship, it is necessary to go on and divide this once more, if we find that it still yields us a cut.

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: And indeed we appear to have one. Just follow along and make the cut with me.

261a

Young Socrates: In what way?

Stranger: In the case of all those we may recognise as ruling by issuing direction, we shall find, won't we, that they are issuing commands for the sake of the generation of something?

Young Socrates: Of course.

Stranger: And, indeed, it is not enormously difficult to divide all that is generated into two.

Young Socrates: In what way?

261b

Stranger: Considering them all together, some, I presume, are soulless, while others are ensouled.

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: And it is just on the basis of these that we shall make a cut in the directing part of purely cognitive knowledge, if we do actually wish to cut it.

Young Socrates: Based on what?

261c

Stranger: By aligning one part of it with the generation that relates to the soulless, and the other with the generation that relates to the ensouled. And in this way the entire, at that stage, can be separated into two.

Young Socrates: Absolutely.

Stranger: Then let us leave one of these parts aside and take up the other one. But having taken it up, we should make a twofold division of all of it.

Young Socrates: Which of the two parts are you saying should be taken up?

Stranger: Presumably the one that issues directions relating to living creatures since the kingly knowledge, unlike architectural knowledge, is of course never the supervisor of the soulless. No, it is nobler, and always has its power over living creatures, and is concerned just with these.

261d

Young Socrates: Correct.

Stranger: However, in the case of living creatures, their coming into being and their nurture may be seen in some cases to be nurture of one animal, while in other cases it is the care, in common, of beasts in herds.

Young Socrates: Correct.

Stranger: But we shall not find the statesman engaging in individual nurture, like an ox driver or a horse trainer. Rather, he bears more resemblance to a horse rancher or a cattle farmer.

Young Socrates: So it appears anyway, when you put it like that.

261e

Stranger: Now in the case of the nurture of living creatures, should we call common nurture of many of them together either herd nurture or nurture in common?

Young Socrates: Whichever occurs to us in the course of the argument.

Stranger: Well said, Socrates! And if you preserve this lack of seriousness towards names, you will prove to be wealthier in wisdom as you approach old age. And we should do exactly as you have directed us. But with regard to herd nurture, can you think of some way that we could show that it is twofold so that what we are now searching for among the pair may be sought thereafter in one of the halves?

262a

Young Socrates: I am eager to do so, and it seems to me that there is a particular sort of nurture concerned with human beings, and a different one concerned with beasts.

Stranger: You made that distinction with enormous eagerness and the utmost courage. However, as best we can, let's not allow this to happen to us again.

Young Socrates: What are you referring to?

262b

Stranger: Let's not separate off one small part relative to many large ones, or proceed without forms. Rather, let the part simultaneously possess form. Indeed, it is all very well to separate immediately what is being sought from the rest, provided it is done properly, just as you thought that you had the division a moment ago when you rushed the argument once you saw that it was moving in the direction of human beings. However, my friend, it is not safe to work with fine divisions. Rather, it is safer to proceed by cutting through the mid-points, for then you would be more likely to encounter forms. This makes all the difference to such enquiries.

262c

Young Socrates: What do you mean by this, stranger?

Stranger: We should attempt to express this even more clearly, Socrates, out of respect for your nature. Now, under the present circumstances it is impossible to present comprehensively, yet I

should endeavour to advance the issue a little further for the sake of clarity.

Young Socrates: Well then, what are you saying we did incorrectly just now, when we were making our divisions?

Stranger: It is as if someone, attempting to divide the human race in two, were to make the division, just as most people in our part of the world make the distribution, separating the Greek race, as one, separate from them the rest, while referring to all the other races together by one name, non-Greek, even though they are unlimited in number, do not mix, and do not share a common language. And on account of this one name, they also presume it to be one race. Or, it's as if someone were to believe he was dividing number on the basis of two forms by cutting off the number ten thousand from all the others, separating it off as one form, and assigning one name to all the remainder. And then, because of the name, went on to presume that this class, a different one from the other one, had come into being. But presumably he would make better divisions, more on the basis of forms, and into two, if he were to cut number into odd and even, and the human race in turn into male and female. He would only split off Lydians or Phrygians,⁴ or any others, from everything else in situations where he was at a loss to discover a part that is, at the same time, also a class for each of the two parts that had been split off.

262e

Young Socrates: Absolutely correct. But just explain this, stranger. How might one recognise more plainly a class and a part as not the same, but as different from one another?

Stranger: Oh, most excellent of men! The task you are assigning me is no ordinary one, Socrates. And although we have now wandered further than necessary from the argument before us, you are asking us to stray even further. Well, we should now do what is reasonable and resume the argument once more, and

come back to these other issues at our leisure, just as trackers do. However, you must be completely on your guard against ever presuming that you have heard me make this distinction plainly.

263a

Young Socrates: What distinction?

Stranger: That form and part are different from one another.

Young Socrates: What should I presume instead?

Stranger: That whenever there is a form of something, then this is also, of necessity, a part of the subject of which it is said to be a form, but there is no necessity whatsoever that a part be a form. You should always say that I formulate it like this rather than the other way.

Young Socrates: That's what I'll do.

263b

Stranger: Well, tell me what comes next.

Young Socrates: What is it?

Stranger: The point of departure of the digression that has led us here. Indeed, I have in mind, in particular, the point where you were asked how 'herd nurture' should be divided, and you replied very eagerly that there are two classes of living creatures, one human and another one consisting of all the rest of the beasts put together.

Young Socrates: True.

263c

Stranger: Well, you seemed to me anyway to believe that having taken away a part, you had left behind a remainder, which, in turn, was one class belonging to all of them, because you were able to assign the same name to them all and call them beasts.

263d

Young Socrates: That is indeed what happened.

Stranger: And yet, my utterly courageous friend, if there were some other animal that is intelligent, as the crane, for instance, or some other such creature seems to be, perhaps they would also assign names on the very same basis as you did, with cranes as a single class set against all other animals, making itself important. And having gathered all the others, along with human beings, into a single class, they would refer to them as nothing in particular, except perhaps beasts. So we should endeavour to be careful of all processes of this sort.

263e

Young Socrates: In what way?

Stranger: By not dividing the entire class of living beings, so that this may be less likely to happen to us.

Young Socrates: Indeed, it shouldn't happen at all.

Stranger: And in fact this is also the way in which we went wrong then.

Young Socrates: How exactly?

Stranger: Belonging to cognitive knowledge that was directive, there was for us, I believe, a part of the animal rearing class, of animals in herds that is. Is this so?

Young Socrates: Yes.

264a

Stranger: Well, at that stage all living creatures together had already been divided into domesticated and wild, for those whose nature is amenable to domestication are referred to as tame, while those that resist it are called wild.

Young Socrates: Good.

Stranger: And yet, the knowledge we are seeking was, and still is, applicable to the tame ones, and it should indeed be sought

among herded beasts.

Young Socrates: Yes.

264b

Stranger: However, let us not make the division just as we did before when we looked to all of them, nor should we hurry so that we may get quickly to statesmanship. Yes, that's what put us in the predicament described by the proverb.

Young Socrates: What predicament?

Stranger: By not being quiet and not making sound divisions, we have reached our destination more slowly.

Young Socrates: And our predicament is a good one, stranger.

Stranger: Be that as it may, let's try to divide common nurture once more from the beginning. For perhaps the detailed conduct of the argument itself will better reveal to you the very thing you are intent upon. Now, tell me something.

Young Socrates: What is it?

264c

Stranger: I want to know if you have often heard people referring to the fish cultivations on the Nile and in the Royal Ponds.⁵ Now, I know you won't have come across them yourself, although you may perhaps be aware of them in fountain pools.

Young Socrates: Yes, indeed, these I have seen, and the others I have heard about from many people.

Stranger: And even if you have not traversed the plains of Thessaly, you have surely learned of their goose farms and crane farms and believe that these exist.

Young Socrates: Of course.

264d

Stranger: The reason I am asking you all these questions is this: it's because the nurture of herds is either water-based or

land-based.

Young Socrates: It is, indeed.

Stranger: So, do you also agree that it is necessary to split the knowledge of common nurture in this way, allocating each of the two parts of it to either of these divisions, and referring to one as water-based nurture and the other as land-based nurture?

264e

Young Socrates: I think so.

Stranger: And, of course, we shall not enquire which of the two skills belongs to kingship, for that is obvious to everyone.

Young Socrates: Of course.

Stranger: Now, in the case of herd nurture, everyone would presumably further divide the land nurture part.

Young Socrates: In what way?

Stranger: By distinguishing the winged and those that go by foot.

Young Socrates: Very true.

Stranger: What about this? Should the statesman not be sought among the sort that goes by foot? Or don't you believe that even an utterly mindless person, so to speak, would accept this?

Young Socrates: I do.

265a

Stranger: And we should demonstrate the skill in managing those that go by foot being cut in two, just like an even number.

Young Socrates: Obviously.

Stranger: And, indeed, it appears that there are two clear approaches towards the part to which our argument is directed. One is quicker since it separates a small part from the large,

while the other is longer but adheres more to the principle we stated previously, whereby we should, for the most part, cut in the middle. So, we can proceed by whichever path we wish.

Young Socrates: Why? Is it impossible to take both?

265b

Stranger: At the same time? How extraordinary! But it is possible of course to take each in turn.

Young Socrates: In that case, I choose each in turn.

Stranger: That is easier, since there is little left for us to do. Yes, at the beginning, or indeed if we were midway through the process, this would be a difficult task for us. But now, since you want to do this, let's go the longer way first, since we shall pursue this more easily when we are fresher. Now, take note of the division.

Young Socrates: Tell me.

Stranger: Our tame creatures that go by foot and live in herds are, by nature, divided in two.

Young Socrates: On what basis?

Stranger: On the basis that some are hornless while the others are horn-bearing.

Young Socrates: Apparently.

265c

Stranger: Now, divide the skill of managing creatures that go on foot, and assign it to each of these parts. But have recourse to a description, for if you ever decide to name them, the issue will get more complicated than necessary.

Young Socrates: So how should it be described?

Stranger: As follows. Once the knowledge of managing those that go on foot has been divided in two, one part is assigned to the horn-bearing part of the herd, and the other to the hornless

part.

Young Socrates: Let them be described like this, for the point has been made abundantly clear.

265d

Stranger: And what's more, it is quite apparent to us that the king is shepherd to some stunted herd of hornless creatures.

Young Socrates: Yes, how could it not be obvious?

Stranger: Then we should break this up and try to grant him the part that belongs to him.

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: Now, do you wish to divide it into split-hoofed and the so-called single-hoofed, or into mixed bred and pure bred? You understand, I presume?

Young Socrates: Understand what?

265e

Stranger: That horses and donkeys, by nature, breed from one another.

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: And yet, the rest of the smooth herd of tame creatures do not interbreed with one another.

Young Socrates: Of course not.

Stranger: Well then, does the statesman appear to have the care of a mixed-bred nature or of something pure bred?

Young Socrates: He obviously has care of the unmixed nature.

Stranger: Then it seems we should break this in two, just as we did in the previous cases.

Young Socrates: Yes, we should do that.

266a

Stranger: And, indeed, the creatures that are tame and live in herds have been almost entirely divided up at this stage, except for two classes. Indeed, the class of dogs does not deserve to be counted among animals living in herds.

Young Socrates: Of course not. But by what are we to separate the two?

Stranger: The very thing by which yourself and Theaetetus may rightly make the division, since you have both taken to geometry.⁶

Young Socrates: By what?

Stranger: By the diagonal, I presume, and once more by the diagonal of the diagonal.

Young Socrates: What do you mean?

266b

Stranger: The nature which our class of human beings has acquired is surely adapted for motion, just like the diagonal which has the power of two feet?

Young Socrates: Just so.

Stranger: Then again, the nature of the remaining class, on the basis of power, is in turn the diagonal of our power, if by nature it is twice two feet.⁷

Young Socrates: How could it not be? And, indeed, I almost understand what you wish to demonstrate.

266c

Stranger: What's more, Socrates, do we see that something has happened to us in the course of these divisions which could be a theme for the greatest comedy?

Young Socrates: In what way?

Stranger: This human race of ours has shared the lot and run the course with the noblest, and at the same time, most

easy-going class of creatures.⁸

Young Socrates: I see. And it is unfolding in a most unusual manner.

Stranger: What about this? Aren't the slowest likely to arrive last?⁹

Young Socrates: Yes, I'll grant you that anyway.

266d

Stranger: And don't we observe that the king appears even more comical as he runs along with the herd, and proceeds down a shared course, as the man who for his part is better trained than anyone for an easygoing life.¹⁰

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: And now, Socrates, the point that was made before, during our investigation into the sophist, is more obvious.¹¹

Young Socrates: What point?

Stranger: That in such a method of argument as this, there is no more concern for what is serious than what is not, and the trivial is given no less respect than the important. Rather, it always reaches the very truest by itself.

Young Socrates: So it seems.

266e

Stranger: After this, shall I proceed down the shorter path we mentioned before, the one that leads to the definition of the king, so that you don't have to ask me?

Young Socrates: Certainly.

267a

Stranger: Well, in that case, I say that those that go by foot should be assigned immediately to the two-footed or the four-footed class, and perceiving the human race still on its own, sharing the lot of those with feathers, we should cut the

two-footed herd once more into featherless and feathered. But once it has been cut, and the skill in managing humans has been made evident, we should take the statesman, the kingly man, like a charioteer, and establish him within it, bestowing upon him the reins of the city as his own, since this knowledge is his.

267b

Young Socrates: You have rendered this account beautifully, and as if I were in your debt, you have added on the digression by way of interest to fill it out.

Stranger: Come on, then. Let's draw together this account of the name of the statesman's skill, by going back over it from the beginning to the end.

Young Socrates: Certainly.

Stranger: Well, at the beginning we had a directive part of cognitive knowledge, and part of this was said, by comparison, to be 'own-directing'. Again, animal nurture, not the smallest of the classes, was split off from 'own-directing'; then a herd nurture form from animal nurture; and then command of those that go by foot from herd nurture; and in particular, from the management of those that go by foot, the skill in nurturing the hornless nature was cut off. But if we wish to construct one name for the subsequent part, it is necessary to weave together no less than three, and refer to it as the knowledge of the shepherding of the unmixed breed. And the cut from this, applied to the two-footed flock, still left the part concerned with the management of humans on its own. And this is already the very thing we sought, the same thing referred to at once as kingly, and as statesman-like.

267c

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

267d

Stranger: Is this really how the matter stands, Socrates? Has our task been accomplished, as you have just said?

Young Socrates: What task?

Stranger: The comprehensive description of the subject in an adequate manner. Yes, our search does lack one feature in particular, that it has somehow given us an account of the matter, but this has not been accomplished perfectly and comprehensively.

Young Socrates: What do you mean?

Stranger: I shall now try to make the very issue I am thinking of even more clear to both of us.

Young Socrates: Please proceed.

Stranger: Of the numerous skills of shepherding that were presented to us just now, was one of the skills statesmanship? And was it the care of one particular kind of herd?

Young Socrates: Yes.

267e

Stranger: Yes. And the argument determined this not as the nurture of horses, or of other beasts either, but as the knowledge of the common nurture of human beings.

Young Socrates: So it did.

Stranger: Let's look at the difference between all other herdsmen and kings.

Young Socrates: What sort of difference?

268a

Stranger: Let's see if any of the others, bearing the name of some other skill, claim to join with the king in the common nurture of the herd, and pretends to do so.

Young Socrates: In what sense do you mean this?

Stranger: Take, for instance, all traders, farmers and bakers, and in addition to these the gymnastic trainers and the class of physicians. Do you realise that these fellows would all battle comprehensively in argument against those shepherds, of all things human, whom we call statesmen, claiming that they are the ones who care for the nurture of humanity, and not only for herds of human beings, but for those who rule over them too?

Young Socrates: And wouldn't they be right to say so?

268b

Stranger: Perhaps. This we shall investigate, but we do know that no one will argue with an oxherd on any of these issues. No, the herdsman himself is the nurturer of the herd. He himself is the physician, and he himself is a sort of matchmaker, and when it comes to childbirth and bringing children into the world, he alone is knowledgeable about midwifery. Then again, insofar as the beasts are naturally able to participate in music and education, no one is more powerful than he at consoling them and charming them into quietude, best at performing the music belonging to his own flock, on instruments or with the unaided voice. And, indeed, the other herdsman have the same manner. Is this so?

Young Socrates: Quite right.

268c

Stranger: Now, how can our argument in relation to the king prove correct and flawless when we install him as the sole herdsman and nurturer of the human herd while singling him out from thousands of others who dispute this assertion?

Young Socrates: We cannot do so at all.

Stranger: In that case, we were right to be afraid a moment ago, suspecting that although we might indeed turn out to be describing some kingly figure, we might not yet have given an accurate portrayal of the statesman until we had stripped away

those who crowd about him and pretend to share his role. And once we had separated him from those fellows, we then revealed him pure and alone.

268d

Young Socrates: You're perfectly right.

Stranger: Then that's what must be done, Socrates, unless we want our argument to end up in disgrace.

Young Socrates: Well, that is something that we must never allow to happen at all.

Stranger: In that case, we need to proceed once more from another starting point based on some different approach.

Young Socrates: What sort of approach?

268e

Stranger: We should mix in some playfulness, since we need to make use in large part of a great story. And thereafter, just as we did previously, arrive at the pinnacle, the object of our search, by continually separating part from part. Isn't that what's needed?

Young Socrates: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: Anyway, apply your mind fully to the story just as children do, since you are not really too long out of your childhood years.

Young Socrates: Please proceed.

Stranger: Well, many events recounted from ancient times have occurred and will occur again, but especially the portent described in the dispute between Atreus and Thyestes. Indeed, I presume you have heard it, and can recall what is said to have happened.¹²

Young Socrates: You are probably referring to the sign of the golden lamb.

269a

Stranger: Not at all, but to the change in the rising and setting of the sun and the other stars. Yes, apparently the sun used to set then in the place where it now rises, and used to rise in the opposite place. However, once the god had borne witness in favour of Atreus, he actually changed this to the present arrangement.

Young Socrates: Yes, indeed, that's what they say too.

269b

Stranger: And what's more, we have also heard from many sources about the kingship that Cronus exercised.

Young Socrates: Yes, from very many.

Stranger: And what about the story that the people of former times were earth-born and were not born from one another?

Young Socrates: That is another one of the ancient accounts.

Stranger: Well, all these originated from the same circumstance, and so do countless others besides that are even more amazing. But due to the great passage of time some of them have been obliterated, while others have been recounted in piecemeal fashion, omitting any connection between them. But no one has explained the circumstance responsible for them all, so that must now be recounted. Indeed, once it has been stated, it will prove relevant to our exposition of the king.

269c

Young Socrates: You have expressed that excellently. Speak on and omit nothing.

Stranger: Please listen. For there is a time when God himself joins directly in guiding the movement of this universe and assists its circling motion, and another time when he lets it go once its revolutions have finally attained the appropriate measure of time, and it is, of itself, led around once more in the opposite direction because it is a living being, allotted

intelligence by the one who constructed it in the beginning. There's a particular reason why this ability to retrace its path is necessarily inherent in its nature.

Young Socrates: What reason?

269d

Stranger: It belongs only to all the most divine things to hold always to the same characteristics and manner, and to be the same, but the nature of body does not partake of this arrangement. And what we refer to as heaven and the universe has inherited numerous blessed qualities from its creator, and yet it does also have communion with body. As a consequence, it is impossible for it to be devoid of change in every respect, and yet to the best of its ability it moves as much as possible in the same place, with a single direction. Therefore, it has been allotted the reverse revolution because that is the smallest possible deviation from its own motion. But it is quite impossible for anything, except that which, for its part, directs the movements of everything, to turn itself continually by itself. But it is not ordained that this causes motion first in one direction and then again in the opposite direction. So, on the basis of all these considerations, we should not assert that the world itself continually turns itself, nor that it is turned entirely by a god in a pair of opposed revolutions, nor again that a pair of gods, whose thinking is opposed, turns it. Rather, the only remaining option is just what we stated earlier. It is guided along by an extraneous divine cause, acquires life once again, and adopts a restored immortality once more from its craftsman. But then, when it is let go, it proceeds by means of itself, having been let go at such a time that it travels in the opposite direction for many thousands of revolutions because, indeed, it is in motion, being most enormous and well-balanced, resting on the smallest pivot.

270a

Young Socrates: Well, it appears that everything you have recounted is very reasonable.

270b

Stranger: Then having reflected upon what has been said, let's come to an understanding of this circumstance, the one we declared to be the cause of all these wonders. In fact, this is it.

Young Socrates: What is it?

Stranger: That the course of the universe revolves at one time in the direction it does now, and at another time in the opposite direction.

270c

Young Socrates: How so?

Stranger: We need to realise that of all the turnings taking place about the heaven, this alteration is the greatest and most comprehensive.

Young Socrates: So it seems, anyway.

Stranger: In that case, we should also presume that at that time enormous changes happen to us who dwell within it.

Young Socrates: This also seems to be the case.

Stranger: And yet, we are also aware that the nature of living beings has difficulty in enduring lots of enormous changes of all sorts when they happen.

Young Socrates: Of course.

270d

Stranger: So, at that stage, enormous destructions are a necessary consequence for living beings in general, and in the case of the human race, only a few survive. Now, numerous other wondrous and novel circumstances befall these people, but there is a most significant one that follows upon the reversal of the motion of the universe whenever the turn,

opposite to what is now established, takes place.

Young Socrates: What is it?

270e

Stranger: Firstly, the ageing process of each of the creatures stood still in all cases, and anything mortal stopped getting older in appearance, but changed once more to the opposite condition, as if it was growing younger and more tender. And the white hair of the older people turned to black, and in the case of the bearded men, their cheeks became smooth once more, and each reverted to a former time of life. And the bodies of the youths, becoming smoother and smaller every day and every night, returned once more to the nature of a new born child, like unto that both in body and in soul. And thereafter, fading away completely, they vanished altogether. What's more, the dead body of anyone who came to a violent end during that era went through the same processes, quickly disappeared in a few days, and was done away with.

271a

Young Socrates: But, stranger, what was the origin of living creatures then? In what manner were they generated from one another?

Stranger: It is clear, Socrates, that generation from one another was not in the nature of things at that time. Instead, the earth-born race that is said to have once existed, the one that returns once more from the earth, was the race that existed in that age. This was remembered by our earliest ancestors, who were born at the beginning of this present age, bordering upon the very end of the previous revolution. Indeed, these ancestors became our proclaimers of these accounts of those earth-born people, accounts that are met with unjustified disbelief by many people these days. Indeed, in my view, we need to consider what else happens. For it follows, from the fact of the return of the old people to the nature of the child, that from those who have

died and are lying in the earth, people are reconstituted there, and coming back to life again they follow the direction of the opposite cycle of generation. And based upon that direction, they necessarily develop as earth-born and are named and described accordingly, except the ones whom God does not preserve for some other destiny.

271c

Young Socrates: Yes, this all follows quite well from what went before. But what about the life that you say is under the power of Cronus? Did that occur during those directions of the cycle, or during these? For it is evident that the change to the stars and the sun occurs during either of the two directions of the cycle.

271d

Stranger: You have followed along with my account quite well. But in relation to your question about the spontaneous generation of everything for humanity, this is least applicable to the present revolution. This also belongs to the previous one. For in that era, god ruled first, caring for the revolution itself as a whole. What's more, the same applied to the individual regions. The parts of the universe were entirely allocated under ruling gods. And, indeed, the living creatures, based on their classes and herds, were adopted by particular daimons, like divine shepherds, each self-sufficient in every respect for each of the creatures he tended, so that none was wild, nor did they eat one another, neither was there any war or discord whatsoever. But details of all the consequences of such an arrangement would be too numerous to recount.

271e

Stranger: Now, what was said about the spontaneous life of human beings was said for the following reason. A god presided over them and managed them himself. Just as humans nowadays, a different and more divine creature now tends upon other kinds of creatures lowlier than itself. While he tended

them, there were no constitutions or any possession of women or children, for they all came to life once more from the earth, remembering nothing of the past. And although this sort of thing was absent, they did have an abundance of fruit from trees, and from lots of other vegetation sent forth spontaneously from the earth, not a product of agricultural activity. They dwelt outdoors for the most part, living off the land, naked and without bedding, for their seasons were a blend, devoid of any distress, and they had soft beds of abundant grass sprung forth from the earth. Socrates, you are now hearing about the life of people under the dominion of Cronus. But the one that is said to be under Zeus, the present one, you are aware of because you are living in it. Now are you able, and indeed willing, to decide which of the two is happier?

272b

Young Socrates: Not at all.

Stranger: In that case, would you like me to make the judgement for you in some way?

Young Socrates: Yes, certainly.

272c

Stranger: Well, if the nurslings of Cronus, enjoying such extensive leisure and the ability to converse through words not only with humans but also with beasts, were to make use of all these advantages for philosophy, associating with beasts and with one another, and finding out from every nature whether any possessed some particular ability to discern something, over and above the others, in relation to the accumulation of understanding, it would be easy to decide that the people of that age vastly exceeded those of this age in happiness. However, if they were to stuff themselves full of food and drink, and converse with one another and the beasts, recounting the sort of tales told about them nowadays, this too, in my view of the matter anyway, would indeed be an easy decision. In any

case, let's set this aside until someone appears who is up to the task of informing us in which of the two ways the people of that age directed their desires regarding knowledge and the use of words.

272d

Stranger: But we should state the reason why we have revived this story, so that we may bring what follows to its conclusion. For when the time for all this had come to an end, and it was necessary for the change to occur – and indeed by then the entire earth-born race had been exhausted, each soul having rendered all its births, each falling to the earth as seed for its allotted number of times – at that stage the helmsman of the universe, as if letting go the handle of the helm, withdrew into his own viewing place, and the allotted and innate desire turned the universe once more in the opposite direction. So all the gods who shared the rule of the regions with the greatest daimon, recognising what was already taking place, withdrew in turn from the parts of the world under their own care. But the universe, in changing direction and being thrown together, the initial and final motions thrusting in opposite directions, produced a considerable convulsion within itself, and thus brought about another destruction of various living beings.

273a

Stranger: Once sufficient time had elapsed thereafter, so that the tumult and confusion had ceased and calm was restored after the convulsions, it adopted the order of its own accustomed course, itself assuming care and control of itself and whatever was in itself, remembering the teaching of its father and maker as best it could. Now, in the beginning this was achieved more precisely, but in the end it was more vague. And the cause of this was the bodily aspect of the combination, the ancient companion of its nature, which had partaken of much disorder before it arrived in the present world. For it has acquired all that is good from its maker, whereas anything that

is troublesome or unjust in the universe it retains from that previous condition, and it engenders this in the living beings. When it nurtures the creatures within itself in company with the helmsman, the baseness it generates is minor, while the good is enormous. However, once it is separated from him, it always deals with everything excellently, during the time closest to the letting go, but with the advance of time and the onset of forgetfulness in itself, the ancient condition of disharmony also exerts more power over it and comes to full bloom towards the end of that era. Then, mixing a little good with a considerable blend of its opposite, it gets to the point at which both itself and whatever is within it are in danger of destruction. Therefore, at that stage, the god who had once put it in order, discerning the difficulties it is in – concerned lest it be storm-tossed by tribulations, break apart, and sink beneath the boundless ocean of diversity – takes his seat once more at its helm, and having reversed the diseases and weaknesses from the former revolution when it was subject to itself, brings order, sets it right, and renders it immortal and unageing.

273e

Stranger: Now, although that concludes all there is to be said, it is sufficient, for the aspect that concerns the presentation of the king, to take note of the earlier part of the account. For once the universe had turned its course once more to the present process of generation, the direction of ageing stood still once more, and new processes opposite to the previous ones were imposed. Those creatures who were just on the point of vanishing due to their smallness grew larger, while the bodies that were new-born from the earth with grey hair, died once more and went back down into the earth. And everything else changed, imitating and following along with the tendencies of the universe. And, indeed, in the case of conception, birth and nurture, their imitation was of necessity in conformity with all else. For it was no longer possible in earth for living beings to be

brought forth through the agency of artificers other than themselves. Rather, just as the universe had been directed to be the independent ruler of its own course, so too, on the same basis, its parts were directed to come forth, be born and develop as best they could, under similar guidance.

274b

Stranger: The entire account was initiated for a purpose, and we have now attained it. Now, in the case of the other animals, it would be a complex and lengthy process to recount in each case what they changed from and what caused the change. However, in the case of human beings it would be shorter and more appropriate. For when we became bereft of the care of the daimon who had acquired and tended us, most of the animals whose natures are troublesome turned wild and preyed upon the humans, who had themselves become weak and unprotected, and in those early years were still devoid of ingenuity or skill, seeing that their spontaneous food source had failed them and they did not yet know how to provide for themselves because they had no compelling need to do so previously. They were facing enormous difficulties on account of all these issues. Hence, those gifts from the gods, described of old, have been bestowed upon us, along with the necessity for teaching and instruction: fire from Prometheus, skills from Hephaestus and his fellow artisan, seeds and plants in turn from other gods. And everything else that has helped the organisation of human life has arisen from these. When, as we said just now, the care of the gods for humanity had failed, they had to maintain guidance and care of themselves by means of themselves, just like the entire world, which we are imitating and following through all time as we live and grow, now in this manner, then in that other manner. So let that be the end of the story. But we shall now make use of it, in order to discern the extent of our error in presenting an account of the king and the statesman in the earlier discussion.

275a

Young Socrates: But how do you say our error occurred, and what was the extent of it?

Stranger: In one sense it was more trivial, but in another sense it was extremely significant, and much greater and more extensive than I thought at the time.

Young Socrates: In what way?

Stranger: When we were asked about the king and statesman belonging to the current revolution and manner of coming into being, we described the shepherd of the human herd belonging to the opposite cycle, and he was a god rather than a mortal, and in this way we went completely wrong. However, when we presented him as ruling the entire city, we did not state the manner of such rule, and in that sense, although we did speak the truth, it was not stated comprehensively or clearly, and therefore we were in error, but to a lesser extent than that.

275b

Young Socrates: True.

Stranger: Then once we have defined the manner of such rule over the city, we should expect accordingly to describe our statesman comprehensively.

Young Socrates: Very good.

Stranger: And it was for these reasons we included the myth, in order to point out not only that when it comes to herd nurture, everyone nowadays disputes over that title with the person we are looking for, but also to discern more clearly, based upon the example of shepherds and cowherds, the one person whom it is appropriate, in view of his care for the nurture of humanity, to deem worthy of this title alone.

275c

Young Socrates: Rightly so.

Stranger: And yet, Socrates, I really think that this figure of the divine herdsman is even greater than that of a king, while the statesmen of the present day have natures much more like those whom they rule over, and they share in an education and nurture closer to their subjects.

Young Socrates: Entirely so, I presume. I suppose that's true, on the whole.

275d

Stranger: Yet they should be sought out anyway, neither more nor less, regardless of whether they have the former or the latter nature.

Young Socrates: They must.

Stranger: Then let's go back once more to this point. We said that the 'own-directing' skill, as applied to living creatures, exercised its care not individually but collectively, and then we referred to it immediately as 'herd-nurture'. You do remember?

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: Well, somehow we went badly wrong on this topic for we utterly failed to include the statesman or to name him. Rather he escaped our naming process without our noticing.

Young Socrates: How?

275e

Stranger: The various other herdsmen share in the nurture of their several herds, but although the statesman has no share in this process, we still applied that name, when we should have applied, to all of them, some name they had in common.

Young Socrates: What you say is true, if there happens to be such a name.

Stranger: Why wouldn't 'ministering' be somehow common to them all, since it is not defined in terms of nurture or any other

particular activity? But if we had called it 'herd-minding' or 'ministration' or 'caring', which is applicable to them all, we would have been able to include the statesman and the others simultaneously, and the argument indicated that this should be so.

276a

Young Socrates: Correct. But in what manner would the next division be made?

Stranger: Based on the same divisions as before, when we divided herd-nurture into foot-borne, un-winged, unmixed in breed, and hornless, and dividing 'herd-minding' on the same basis, we would presumably be encompassing kingship of today, and of the age of Cronus alike, in our account.

Young Socrates: Apparently, but I am still asking what comes next.

276b

Stranger: It is obvious that if the word 'herd-minding' had been used in this context, the contention that there is no care whatsoever would never have occurred to us, which is just what happened when it was rightly contended that in the case of humans, there is no skill worthy of the title 'nurturing'. And even if there were such a skill, many people have a prior and better claim to it than any of our kings.

Young Socrates: Correct.

276c

Stranger: But when it comes to the common care of humanity in its entirety, no other skill would wish to assert a prior and better claim than kingly rule, which is the rule of all human beings.

Young Socrates: What you say is correct.

Stranger: And yet, Socrates, after all this, do we recognise that a considerable further error was made at the very end?

Young Socrates: Of what sort?

Stranger: As follows. If we really did think that there was a skill of nurturing herds of bipeds, we should not have referred to it immediately as kingship or statesmanship with such finality.

Young Socrates: What then?

276d

Stranger: Firstly, as we are saying, we should have changed the manner of the name, orienting it towards care rather than nurture, and then made a cut in this. Indeed, it still has capacity for significant cuts.

Young Socrates: Of what sort?

Stranger: A cut, I presume, whereby we could have separated the divine shepherd and the human carer apart.

Young Socrates: Correct.

Stranger: And yet it was necessary to cut the caring which has been parted off into two once more.

Young Socrates: Into what?

Stranger: Into enforced and voluntary.

Young Socrates: Why so?

276e

Stranger: Well, I think this is how we went wrong previously when, proceeding more simplistically than we should, we treated the king and the tyrant as the same, although they are quite dissimilar in themselves and in the manner of their particular rule.

Young Socrates: True.

Stranger: But now, correcting ourselves once more, should we make a twofold division of the care of humanity into enforced and voluntary, just as I said?

Young Socrates: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: And presumably the herd-minding of subjects who are forced is tyrannical, while the voluntary herd-minding of willing two-legged creatures should be called statesmanship, and we should affirm that the one who, for his part, possesses this skill and care is really a king and statesman.

277a

Young Socrates: Indeed, stranger, it is likely that our exposition of the statesman may have reached a conclusion.

Stranger: That would be excellent for us, Socrates. But it is necessary for me to share these views with you, in common, so that they are not just your views. Right now, in my view anyway, it seems we have not yet arrived at a figure of the king that is complete. Rather, just as sculptors sometimes cause delay by rushing inappropriately to make greater and more numerous additions than necessary to parts of their work, so too have we, presumably with the aim of presenting a quick and high-sounding demonstration of the error in our previous process, considered it appropriate to apply elaborate examples to the king, and drawing upon a wondrous chunk of the myth, we were compelled to employ a greater part of it than was necessary. Therefore, we have made the exposition longer, and have failed to bring a conclusion to the story fully. Indeed, our account, just like a sketch of a living creature, has a fairly adequate outline, but has not yet been given actuality as it were, from pigments and the blending of colours. But for those who are able to follow, it is more fitting to reveal every living creature through speech and argument, rather than through drawing and all sorts of craftsmanship. But for everyone else, we should resort to craftsmanship.

277c

Young Socrates: That is correct. But please reveal the way in which, according to you, we have not yet described this

adequately.

Stranger: It is difficult, my divine friend, to present anything of significance in an adequate manner without recourse to exemplars. For it is likely that each of us knows all that we know as though in a dream, and then again, when we really are awake, are ignorant of everything.

Young Socrates: What do you mean by that?

277d

Stranger: Yes. In a strange way I seem at the moment to have raised the issue of the experience of knowledge within us.

Young Socrates: In what way?

Stranger: Blessed man, my example itself stands in turn in need of an example.

Young Socrates: Why so? Speak, and do not hesitate on my account.

Stranger: Speak I must, since you are ready to follow. We know, I presume, that children, whenever they are first developing their skill in writing...

Young Socrates: What do we know?

Stranger: That they adequately recognise each of the letters in the shortest and easiest syllables, and become capable of speaking the truth in relation to those.

Young Socrates: Of course.

277e

Stranger: And yet they are doubtful about the very same letters in other syllables, and their opinions and formulations are false.

Young Socrates: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: Now wouldn't the easiest and best way to lead them on to what they do not yet recognise be as follows?

Young Socrates: How is it done?

278a

Stranger: Firstly, to take them back to those instances in which their opinions on these same letters were correct, and having done so, then place these alongside the ones they do not yet recognise, and by comparing them, point out that there is the same common feature and characteristic present in both intertwinings, until such time as all the cases where their opinions are true have been shown, alongside all of those they don't know about. Accordingly, these act as examples that make them, in the case of all letters in all the syllables, refer to each as different insofar as it is different from the others, and as the same insofar as it is always the same as itself in the same respect.

278b

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: So, have we fully appreciated that example has its origin when something that is the same is appreciated correctly in a different, separate context, and the two contexts, by being brought together, a single true opinion about each instance and both instances together is attained?

278c

Young Socrates: Apparently so.

Stranger: Well, would we be surprised if our soul, by nature, underwent this same process in relation to the letters of the universe, sometimes standing in a true relation to each one in a particular case, then again all at sea about all of them under different circumstances, somehow or other recognising some of the combinations correctly. But once these are transposed to the lengthy and difficult syllables of human affairs, it is ignorant once more of these same letters.

278d

Young Socrates: That would be nothing particularly surprising.

278e

Stranger: How could anyone, my friend, who begins from false opinion, arrive at even a small portion of truth and acquire understanding?

Young Socrates: That is well-nigh impossible.

Stranger: Well, if that's how things naturally operate, you and I would not go much astray if, having first attempted to discern the nature of example as a whole, we were to discern it in turn in a further minor example, and transposing these processes thereafter to the very important matter of the king, we were to apply the same format and proceed from the lesser. Thereafter, we should endeavour, through an example, by means of a skill, to understand the ministration towards those who live in a city so that it becomes a waking reality for us and no mere dream.

Young Socrates: That is surely correct.

279a

Stranger: Then we should take up that earlier argument once more, that since thousands dispute with the kingly class over the care of the city, it is necessary to separate off all these competitors and leave that single personage. And we said that, to this end, we do indeed need an example.

Young Socrates: Very much so.

279b

Stranger: Then, what example, an insignificant one, involving the same activity as the statesman, might someone set beside it and discover what we are seeking well enough? By Zeus, Socrates, do you want, if we have nothing to hand, at least to choose weaving? And if you agree, not all of it? In fact, the weaving of items made of wool will probably suffice. Indeed, if we select it, this part of it is likely to provide the evidence we desire.

Young Socrates: Yes, why not?

279c

Stranger: Then why not do just what we did before when we divided each object by cutting parts into parts. Let's do the same thing now in relation to weaving, and as best we can go over everything again as briefly as possible, and arrive at what is useful to us now.

Young Socrates: What do you mean?

Stranger: I shall make the exposition itself my answer to you.

Young Socrates: Excellent.

279d

Stranger: Well, in the case of everything we produce or acquire, some are for the purpose of doing something, while others are a defence against suffering something. Now, some of the defences are antidotes, whether divine or human, while others are barriers. And some of the barriers are military armaments, while others are screens. And some of the screens are covers, while others are protections against heat and cold. And some of the protections are shelters, others are blankets. And some of the blankets are carpets, while a different sort are garments. And some of the garments are cut from one piece, while a different sort are put together. And some of the put-together garments are sewn, while others are put together without sewing. And some of those that are unsewn are made from the fibres of plants from the earth, others from hair. And some of those made from hair are held together by water or earth, while others bind themselves together by themselves. Now, we give the name clothes to those blankets and defences produced from materials bound together by themselves, while the skill that is particularly concerned with clothes – in the exact same way that we once said statesmanship is concerned with the city – should we now refer to this as 'clothes-making', naming it after the activity itself? And should we also state that weaving, insofar as it is for the most part the production of

clothes, differs in nothing but name from that skill in clothes-making, just as in the other consideration kingship did not differ from statesmanship?

280a

Young Socrates: You are absolutely right about that anyway.

280b

Stranger: Yet we should recognise after this, that once the weaving of garments has been described in this way, someone might presume that it has been adequately described because he is unable to understand that although it has been distinguished from numerous other kindred skills, it has not yet been separated from its closest collaborators.

Young Socrates: What sort of kindred skills do you mean?

Stranger: It appears you did not follow what was said, so it seems we must go back once more and begin where we ended. Yes. If you understand me, we have already cut off its closest relations by separating the assembly of blankets into those that are wrapped around and those that are placed beneath.

Young Socrates: I understand.

280c

Stranger: And, indeed, we set aside all manufacturing out of flax or rushes and out of everything we described summarily just now as plant fibres. And furthermore, we set aside felt-making and the putting together that employs stitching and sewing, the most significant of which is shoe-making.

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

280d

Stranger: And what's more, leather-working ministers to blankets of one piece, and all those activities concerned with shelters, and any that are involved in house-building, in carpentry as a whole, and in other skills that protect against the influx of water. All these we set aside. Also, any skills concerned

with shelters, and which provide preventive products against theft and violent actions, and involve the making of lids and the fitting of doors, and are designated as parts of the skill of joinery. We also cut away the making of armaments, which was a significant and extensive division of the barrier-making power. And, indeed, at the very outset we separated off the entire skill of magic that is concerned with antidotes. And we are left with what we take to be a defence against cold weather, the very skill we were looking for, the one that manufactures a woollen barrier and has been given the name weaving.

280e

Young Socrates: Yes, that's how it seems.

Stranger: But, my boy, having said all this, it is still not complete, for the process involved at the start of the manufacture of clothing appears to do the opposite of weaving.

Young Socrates: How so?

Stranger: The process of weaving is presumably a kind of intertwining.

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: And yet there is an initial process of breaking apart materials that have been combined and forced together.

Young Socrates: What sort of process do you mean?

281a

Stranger: The process associated with the skill of the carder of wool. Or shall we dare to refer to carding as weaving, or to the carder as though he were a weaver?

Young Socrates: Not at all.

Stranger: And, indeed, if anyone refers to the production of the warp and the woof as weaving, he is assigning a name that is both bizarre and false.

Young Socrates: He is, indeed.

281b

Stranger: What about this? Should we propose the entire skill of the fuller, and that of clothes-mending, are not in any sense either the care of clothes or attention to them, or shall we also refer to these as weaving skills?

Young Socrates: Not at all.

Stranger: And yet, these will all dispute with the power of the weaving skill about the attention to, and the production of, clothes, conceding the largest part to that power, while allocating important parts to themselves too.

281c

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: Then, in addition to these claimants, it seems necessary that the skills that produce the instruments whereby the processes of weaving are accomplished will also pretend to be at least contributory causes of everything that is woven.

Young Socrates: Absolutely correct.

281d

Stranger: Now, will our account dealing with the part of weaving we have selected be definite enough, provided we position the skill as "the noblest and greatest of all those that are concerned with the care of woollen clothes"? Or would we be stating something true, but neither clear nor complete until we have also taken away all those skills that surround it?

Young Socrates: Correct.

Stranger: So, shouldn't we go on to do what we are saying so that our account may proceed in due order?

Young Socrates: Of course.

Stranger: Then we should first look at two skills that are involved in all activities.

Young Socrates: What are they?

Stranger: The contributory cause of the production, and also the cause itself.

Young Socrates: How so?

281e

Stranger: Contributory causes are those which do not produce the product itself, but provide instruments to those who do produce it, without which the activity allotted to each of the skills would never take place. However, those that bring the product itself into existence are causes.

Young Socrates: Well, that makes sense anyway.

Stranger: So after this, should we refer to all that is concerned with spindles, shuttles and any other instruments that are involved in the production of garments as contributory causes, and those that minister to and produce the garments themselves as causes?

Young Socrates: Quite right.

282a

Stranger: Now, in the realm of causes, since the skill of adorning is so extensive, it is probably best to include clothes-cleaning, clothes-mending and any ministration associated therewith as part of this, and assign all of it the name 'the skill of the fuller'.

Young Socrates: Very well.

Stranger: And, indeed, carding and spinning, and everything which for its part concerns the manufacture of the clothing itself, the parts of which we are describing, is a single skill, one whose name is familiar to everyone – wool-working.

Young Socrates: Of course.

282b

Stranger: Now there are two divisions of wool-working, and each of these is, at the same time, part of two skills.

Young Socrates: How so?

Stranger: Carding, and one half of the activity associated with the shuttle, and any processes that separate compounded things from one another – all these can presumably be said to belong, as one, to wool-working itself. And we said that there are two particular major skills applicable to everything, combination and separation.

Young Socrates: Yes.

282c

Stranger: Well, carding and all the activities we mentioned just now are parts of the skill of separating, for the separation into woof and warp, arising in one way by means of the shuttle, and in another way by means of the hand, has acquired as many names as we mentioned a moment ago.

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: Then again, we should once more take a part of the skill of combining, a part that is at the same time a part of wool-working. Let's set aside the entire skill of dividing we find there, and cut wool-working into two parts, separative and combinative.

282d

Young Socrates: Let the division be made.

Stranger: Then, Socrates, you should go on to divide the part that at once involves combination and wool-working if we are going to properly apprehend the aforementioned skill of weaving.

Young Socrates: So that's what's needed.

Stranger: It is needed. So, let's say that one part of it is twisting while the other is intertwining.

Young Socrates: Do I understand you? You seem to be referring to the process involved in the production of the warp as twisting.

Stranger: Not only of the warp, but of the woof too. Or shall we expect to find some origin for the woof that avoids twisting?

Young Socrates: Not at all.

Stranger: Then you should also distinguish each of these two, for perhaps the distinction may prove opportune for you.

Young Socrates: In what way?

282e

Stranger: As follows. Are the products of the carding process, once they have been lengthened and have also acquired breadth, referred to as drawn wool?

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: Well, any of this that has been twisted by the spindle and has become hard yarn, you call warp yarn, and the skill that directs this, warp-spinning.

Young Socrates: Correct.

Stranger: While any threads that for their part undergo a loose twisting and possess a measure of softness appropriate to being woven into the warp – in view of the force applied in the dressing of the cloth – these we call woof yarn, and the skill that presides over them we call woof-spinning.

283a

Young Socrates: Quite right.

Stranger: And so, the part of weaving which we have been pursuing is presumably evident to everyone by now. For whenever the combinative part that is involved in

wool-working produces a web by directly intertwining woof and warp, the entire web is referred to as a woollen garment, and the skill set over it as weaving.

Young Socrates: Quite right.

283b

Stranger: So be it. Now, why ever did we not reply straight away that weaving was the twining of woof and warp, instead of going around in a circle, pointlessly making a whole range of distinctions?

Young Socrates: Well, stranger, nothing that was said seemed pointless to me, anyway.

Stranger: That is no surprise, bless you, but perhaps in time it may seem so. Well, to counteract such a malady as this, in case it ever afflicts you in future – which would be no surprise – listen to an argument which it is appropriate to state concerning everything like this.

Young Socrates: Please state it.

283c

Stranger: Well, in the first place, let's look at all excess and deficiency so that we attribute praise and blame on a reasonable basis, on occasions when the speeches involved in discussions of this sort are longer than necessary, or the opposite.

Young Socrates: That's what's needed.

283d

Stranger: Well, if our discussion was about these issues themselves, I think it would be proceeding correctly.

Young Socrates: About what issues?

Stranger: About length and brevity and all excess and deficiency, for I presume that the skill of measurement is concerned with all these?

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: Then we should distinguish two parts of this, since that's what is necessary for our present objective.

Young Socrates: Please tell us how to make the division.

Stranger: As follows. One corresponds to the shared interrelationship of greatness and smallness, and the other corresponds to the being necessary for becoming.

Young Socrates: What do you mean?

283e

Stranger: Well, don't you think it is natural that the greater should be referred to as greater than nothing else except the lesser, and the lesser for its part as lesser than nothing other than the greater?

Young Socrates: I do.

Stranger: What about this? Won't we say also that exceeding the nature of the measure, and being exceeded by it, be it in word or deed, does actually happen. And this is how those who are good and those who are bad among us are chiefly distinguished?

Young Socrates: Apparently so.

Stranger: So, we should propose then that things can be, and can be judged to be, great and small in these two ways. But we should not state, as we did a moment ago, that they only relate to one another. Rather, as we are now saying, we should declare that they relate to one another, but also to the measure. Would you like to understand why we should say so?

Young Socrates: Of course.

284a

Stranger: If we allow the nature of the greater to relate to nothing except to the lesser, it will never relate to the measure.

Is this so?

Young Socrates: Quite so.

Stranger: In that case, won't we destroy both the skills themselves and their products in their entirety by this argument, and what's more, obliterate the statesmanship we are now seeking and the weaving we have been describing? For all such skills are, somehow, vigilant about excess and deficiency of the measure, regarding it not as something that is not, but as something that is a difficult aspect of their activities, and indeed by so doing they preserve the measure and make everything good and beautiful.

284b

Young Socrates: Of course.

Stranger: And if we should obliterate statesmanship, our subsequent search for the knowledge of kingship will be blocked.

Young Socrates: Very much so.

Stranger: Then, just as in considering the sophist we compelled what is not to be when the argument got away from us on this issue, so too mustn't we now compel the more and the less, for their part, to come to be measured not only in relation to one another, but also in relation to the source of the measure? Indeed, unless this has been agreed, it is not actually possible that a statesman, or anyone else with knowledge of practical matters, should come into being in an undisputed manner.

284c

Young Socrates: In that case, as best we can, we must do the same thing now.

Stranger: This topic, Socrates, is more extensive than that earlier one, and you do remember how long that was. However, it is most appropriate to put forward the following hypothesis

about them.

Young Socrates: What is it?

284d

Stranger: That what has been said now will be needed some time for the demonstration of the utmost precision. But for our present purposes, what is being demonstrated beautifully and adequately seems to be supported magnificently by this argument of ours, according to which we should think that all the skills exist in like manner, and at the same time, that greater and less are to be measured not only in relation to one another, but also in relation to the source of the measure. For if this measure exists, then those skills exist, and if they exist, then this also exists, and if either of these doesn't exist, neither will ever exist.

Young Socrates: That's right. But what comes after this?

284e

Stranger: Obviously we would divide the skill of measurement in the manner stated, cutting it into two, and designating one part of it as all those skills that measure number, length, depth, breadth, and speed in relation to their opposites. While the other one measures them in relation to the measure, to what is appropriate, timely, necessary, and whatever else betakes itself away from the extremes towards the mean.

285a

Young Socrates: Yes. Each of the divisions you describe is significant, and very different from one another.

Stranger: Yes, Socrates. Many refined thinkers, believing themselves to be stating something wise, declare that measurement is concerned with everything that comes into being, and this is just what we are saying. For, in a sense, everything that involves a skill partakes of measurement. And yet, because people are unaccustomed to investigation by

dividing on the basis of forms, they immediately combine these together as the same, despite their degree of difference, since they regard them as similar. And they also do the opposite of this, separating what is different, but not on the basis of its parts. What is necessary is that when someone first perceives what is common to many, he should not desist until he beholds therein all the differences that repose within their forms. On the other hand, when he beholds the variety of dissimilarities in multiplicities, he must be incapable of getting disconcerted and stopping until, having brought all the kindred into one particular class of likeness, he encompasses them in being.

285c

Stranger: Now, let these statements concerning these matters suffice, and also those concerning deficiencies and excesses. However, let's just note carefully that two kinds of measurement concerning these have been discovered, and let us remember what we say they are.

Young Socrates: We shall remember.

Stranger: Well, after this account we should entertain another consideration concerning the very things we are seeking, and concerning all conduct of discussions of this sort.

Young Socrates: What is it?

285d

Stranger: Suppose someone were to ask us about students learning their letters. Whenever one of them is asked what letters make up a particular word, would we say that the query is presented to him on that occasion more for the sake of the word, the one he is presented with, or for the sake of his becoming more skilled in all words he comes across?

Young Socrates: Obviously it is for the sake of becoming skilled in all of them.

Stranger: And what about our present enquiry concerning the statesman? Has it been posed more for the sake of this person himself or for the sake of becoming more skilled in dialectic concerning everything?

Young Socrates: In this case too, it is obviously for the sake of everything.

285e

Stranger: Yes. I presume that no one in his right mind would wish to pursue this account of weaving for the sake of the subject itself. But I think most people overlook the fact that readily comprehensible, perceptible likenesses are naturally present for some of the things that are, and it is not at all difficult to present these when one wishes to give an easy demonstration to someone who asks for an account thereof which is uncomplicated and non-verbal. However, in the case of the most significant and revered of the things that are, there is no image at all wrought in clear view before humanity, by pointing to which someone who wishes to satisfy the soul of an enquirer may do so in an adequate manner by fitting it to some aspect of our sense perceptions. Therefore, it is necessary to practise being able to give and to receive an account of each. For the things that are devoid of body, being the most beautiful and the most significant, are shown clearly by the argument alone, and by nothing else, and all that we are now saying is said for the sake of those. But it is easier to practise anything on lesser matters rather than greater ones.

286b

Young Socrates: You have expressed that perfectly.

Stranger: Then let us recall the reasons why we have had so much to say about all this.

Young Socrates: What were they?

286c

Stranger: Not least was the aversion we felt over the lengthy account which dealt with weaving, and over the reverse-motion of the universe, and, in the case of the sophist, the being of non-being when we realised how very lengthy it was. And we rebuked ourselves over all of this, fearing that we might be stating something over-elaborate as well as lengthy. So we should declare that everything we have said so far was on account of these concerns, so that nothing of this sort should happen to us again.

Young Socrates: Be it so. Just say what comes next.

286d

Stranger: Well, I say that it is necessary for you and me, remembering what has just been said, to allocate censure and praise on each occasion for the brevity and, at the same time, the length involved in the expositions we so often deliver by judging their length not in relation to one another, but on the basis of the part of the skill of measuring that we said we should remember – namely, in relation to what is appropriate.

Young Socrates: Rightly so.

286e

Stranger: Yes. But this is not applicable in all cases, for we shall not have need of length which is added on for the sake of pleasure, except as a secondary consideration. And again, in relation to the enquiry into the issue before us, the argument directs us to favour the easiest and quickest approach as something we should seek out as a second priority, not as a first. First and foremost, we should respect the method itself, by which we are able to make divisions on the basis of forms. And, indeed, should a discussion prove inordinately lengthy, and yet place the hearer in a better position to make discoveries, we should take it seriously and be untroubled by its duration. And the same applies if it is very short. Furthermore, besides these considerations, someone who criticises gatherings of this sort,

due to the length of the discussions, and finds the circular course of the arguments hard to accept, should not be allowed to turn and go on the spot, in all haste, having levelled his criticism solely on the basis of the length of what was said. No, he should also prove that we should accept that the people present would have been rendered more skilled in dialectic – and better at discovering the exposition of things that are – by an account, had the process been made shorter. As for the other criticisms and praises based on other criteria, we should not think about them, or even seem to hear such arguments at all.

287a

Stranger: Anyway, that's enough on these issues, provided you agree with me on this. So we should go back to the statesman and apply to him the example of weaving as described before.

287b

Young Socrates: That is well expressed, and we should do as you say.

Stranger: Now, the king has at least been separated from the many skills that are kindred, or rather from all of those that are concerned with herds. What remains, we say, are the contributory causes, and the causes applicable to the city itself. And these we should first separate from one another.

Young Socrates: Correct.

287c

Stranger: Now, do you realise that it is difficult to cut these in two? The reason, I believe, will become evident anyway as we proceed.

Young Socrates: In that case, we should do as you say.

Stranger: Then let's divide it at its limbs, like a sacrificial animal. And since we are unable to make a division into two, it is necessary always to cut it into a number that is as close to two as possible.

Young Socrates: But how should we do so in this case?

Stranger: Just as we did before, when we designated all the skills that provide tools related to weaving as contributory causes.

Young Socrates: Yes.

287d

Stranger: And now we should do the same thing, but more extensively than before. Indeed, whatever skills produce any significant or insignificant tools for the city should all be designated as contributory causes, for, without these, neither city nor statesmanship would ever come into existence. Yet, on the other hand, I presume we shall not designate any of these as belonging to the work of the skill of kingship.

Young Socrates: No, indeed.

Stranger: And, indeed, we are undertaking a difficult task in separating this class from the others. For it is possible for someone to maintain that anything whatsoever is an instrument of something or other, and seem to be making a persuasive case. Nevertheless, we should mention a particular one of the city's possessions that is different.

Young Socrates: In what sense?

287e

Stranger: Insofar as it does not possess this ability to act as an instrument. For it is not constructed to act as a cause of some production, as is the case with an instrument, but constructed in order to preserve what has been produced.

Young Socrates: What sort of thing is this?

Stranger: Well, this is a variegated object, wrought for dry goods, for liquids, for use on the fire and for general use. We call it by a single name, 'vessel', and this very commonplace object does not, in my view, belong at all to the knowledge we are

looking for anyway.

Young Socrates: No, how could it?

288a

Stranger: Well, we should also take note of a third extensive object, different from these possessions of the city. It goes by land and by water, it wanders a lot and does not wander, it is worthy of reverence and unworthy of reverence. And yet it bears a single name, because all are intended for sitting upon, and always act as a seat for someone.

Young Socrates: What is it?

Stranger: I presume we call it a carriage, so it is not really the work of statesmanship, but much more of carpentry, pottery-making and bronze-working.

Young Socrates: I understand.

288b

Stranger: What about a fourth? Should we say that there is something different from those three, one that includes most of what we mentioned some time ago – all sorts of clothing, most armaments, walls, and all enclosures whether of earth or of stone, and myriads of others? Since all these are produced for defensive purposes, it would be most appropriate to refer to them as a whole as a barrier, and to regard this more correctly as belonging much more to the work of the builder's skill or to weaving, for the most part, rather than statesmanship.

Young Socrates: Yes, certainly.

288c

Stranger: And as a fifth, would we like to suggest adornment and painting and whatever imitations are effected through their use, and through music, which having been produced solely for our pleasure are quite rightly captured by a single name?

Young Socrates: What is it?

Stranger: We do use the term 'plaything', I presume.

Young Socrates: Of course.

288d

Stranger: Well, it will be appropriate to assign this one name to them all, for none of them has any serious purpose. Rather, they are all done for the sake of amusement.

Young Socrates: That too is something I understand fairly well.

Stranger: And that which provides all these with the materials from which, and in which, any of the skills mentioned just now do their work – a variegated sort that owes its origin to many different skills – shall we designate this as a sixth?

Young Socrates: What sort of thing are you referring to?

288e

Stranger: Gold and silver and anything whatsoever that is mined; and whatever all felling and lopping of trees provides to carpentry and basket-weaving, through the cutting process; and again, the stripping of bark from trees; and leather-working which strips the skins from the bodies of ensouled creatures, and any skills related thereto; and the ability to produce cork and papyrus and ropes. All these enable the manufacture of compounded forms from classes that are not compounded. Let's refer to it all as one, the primeval acquisition of humanity, uncompounded too, and in no way the work of kingly knowledge.

Young Socrates: Very well.

289a

Stranger: Then the acquisition of nutriment and whatever mixes into the body, and mixing parts of itself with parts of the body has some power to promote its health, should be called the seventh. And we should give the name 'nurture' to the totality,

if we don't have anything better to suggest. And if we place it entirely under farming, hunting, gymnastic, medicine and cookery rather than statesmanship, we shall be allocating it more correctly.

Young Socrates: Of course.

289b

Stranger: Well, I think anything pertaining to acquisition, except that of tame animals, has been quite well described under these seven classes. Let's review them. Indeed, it would be most appropriate to place the primeval form at the beginning, after this 'instrument', 'vessel', 'carriage', 'barrier', 'plaything' and 'nourishment'. But if we have omitted anything it can be included in one of these, provided it is something insignificant that has been overlooked, such as the class made up of currency, seals and stamps of all sorts. For these in themselves do not constitute a significant common class. But if some are dragged into the category of adornments, others into that of instruments, they will, despite the force, be entirely concordant therewith. Then everything concerned with the acquisition of tame animals, with the exception of slaves, turns out to have been encompassed by the herd-nurturing skill that we divided into parts earlier.

289c

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: What remains are all slaves and underlings, among whom, I somehow anticipate, those who dispute with the king over the woven web itself will become evident, just as earlier those concerned with spinning and carding, and all the others we mentioned, disputed with the weavers. But all the others, the contributory causes as we called them, have been disposed of along with the works we listed just now, and they have been separated off from the activity of kingship and statesmanship.

289d

Young Socrates: So they seem, anyway.

Stranger: Come on, let's consider those who remain by getting closer to them, so that we may recognise them with more certainty.

Young Socrates: That's what's needed.

Stranger: Then, from this perspective, we shall find the greatest servants possessing the opposite habit and character to those we anticipated.

289e

Young Socrates: Who are they?

Stranger: Those who are bought, and constitute acquisitions in this sense, whom we may indisputably refer to as slaves, and who have the least pretensions to the kingly skill.

Young Socrates: Of course.

Stranger: But what about those who are free, but willingly assign themselves in servitude to the people we just mentioned by conveying the works of agriculture and the other skills to one another and distributing them out, some resorting to the marketplace, others travelling from city to city by sea and by land, exchanging money for goods and money for money, to whom we have given the name of money-changers, merchants, ship owners and retailers? Surely they will not lay any claim to statesmanship?

290a

Young Socrates: Except, perhaps, insofar as it relates to trading.

Stranger: But surely those whom we see so readily serving anyone at all, as hired labourers for payment, would never be found laying claim to kingship.

Young Socrates: No, how could they?

Stranger: But what about those who provide services of a different sort?

Young Socrates: What services do you mean, and to whom are you referring?

290b

Stranger: The people involved in communications, and those who become wise in written matters through their constant service, and some others who are well able to work out numerous other issues relating to public offices. What shall we call these people?

Young Socrates: Servants, as you explained just now. But they are not the people who rule in our cities.

Stranger: But I don't think, anyway, that I was in a dream when I said that those who assert the strongest claim to statesmanship would somehow make their appearance in this. And yet, it does seem most unusual to look for them in some subdivision of servitude.

Young Socrates: Quite so.

290c

Stranger: Then let's get into closer contact with those who have not yet been scrutinised. There are people who possess a portion of some serviceable knowledge of prophecy. Indeed, they are somehow regarded as interpreting from the gods to humanity.

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: And there is also the class of priests, which, according to tradition, is knowledgeable in bestowing gifts from us upon the gods through sacrifices that are acceptable to them, and also in requesting from them the acquisition of good things for us through prayers. But both of these are part of a servile skill.

290d

Young Socrates: So it appears anyway.

Stranger: Well, at this stage we seem to me to have encountered a sort of footprint of the person we are pursuing. For the personage associated with priests and prophets is well stocked with exalted notions, and acquires a reputation for sanctity because of the importance of what he engages in, so that, in Egypt, the king is not permitted to rule without being a priest. And if even he attains the role in the first place by forcing his way in from some other class, it is still necessary for him to be initiated later on into the priestly class. And even among the Greeks, one would find that the performance of the most important sacrifices of this kind are assigned to the most important office holders. And, indeed, what I am saying is no less evident among yourselves here, for it is said that the performance of the most solemn and most traditional of the ancient sacrifices is allocated to the king,¹³ whom you choose by lot.

291a

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: Then we should investigate these kings chosen by lot, who are also priests, and their servants, and another extensive crowd of people who have become evident to us, now that the previous candidates have been set aside.

Young Socrates: What people are you referring to?

Stranger: Some very unusual people indeed.

Young Socrates: Why so?

291b

Stranger: They appear, as I now see it, to belong to an extremely varied class. For many of these men resemble lions, centaurs and other such creatures; very many more are like satyrs, and those weak creatures that adopt many guises, and

they rapidly assume each other's characteristics and ability. And, indeed, Socrates, I think I have just appreciated who these men are.

Young Socrates: Please tell us, for you seem to have discerned something unusual.

291c

Stranger: Yes, for in all cases the unusual is a consequence of ignorance. Indeed, I also experienced this myself just now. I was suddenly thrown into doubt when I beheld the chorus concerned with the affairs of our cities.

Young Socrates: What did you see?

Stranger: The greatest beguiler among all the sophists and the person most experienced in this skill – someone who, despite the extreme difficulty of doing so, must be separated from those who really are statesmen and kings, if we are going to catch clear sight of what we are looking for.

Young Socrates: Then we really must not relent in this.

Stranger: Certainly not. Not in my view, anyway. So tell me this.

Young Socrates: What?

291d

Stranger: Isn't monarchy, for us, one of the modes of civic rule?

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: I think someone might propose that the exercise of power by a few people comes after monarchy.

Young Socrates: Of course.

Stranger: And isn't the third form of constitution the rule of the multitude, referred to by the name 'democracy'?

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: And being three, don't they in some sense become five, engendering two other names from themselves in addition to their own?

Young Socrates: What are they?

291e

Stranger: Nowadays, people focus upon the degree of compulsion and willingness, poverty and wealth, law and lawlessness arising in these. And dividing each of them into two, they refer to monarchy by two names on the basis that it constitutes two forms, the tyrannical and the kingly.

Young Socrates: Of course.

Stranger: And whenever the city is under the power of the few, it is called aristocratic or oligarchic.

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: And yet, in the case of democracy, whether the multitude rules over the possessors of wealth by force or with their consent, or whether they pay close attention to the laws or not, it is not the usual practice for anyone to change its name.

292a

Young Socrates: True.

Stranger: What now? Do we think that any of these constitutions is the right one, when it is defined based on these distinctions between one, few and multitude, wealth and poverty, compulsion and willingness, and whether it happens to operate under written laws or without such laws?

Young Socrates: Is there any particular reason why not?

292b

Stranger: Well, consider it more clearly by following this argument.

Young Socrates: Which?

Stranger: Shall we stand by what we said at the outset or shall we dispute it?

Young Socrates: What are you referring to?

Stranger: We said, I believe, that kingly rule is one of the branches of knowledge.

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: And it did not belong to all of them. Rather, we preferred one that was judged and one that was directive over the others.

Young Socrates: Yes.

292c

Stranger: And from the directive category we selected one that applied to inanimate products, and another that applied to living beings. And so, making divisions in this manner, we have been continually approaching this point where, without losing sight of knowledge, we are as yet unable to adequately describe precisely what the knowledge is.

Young Socrates: What you are saying is correct.

Stranger: So, do we appreciate this particular point, that the definition of these constitutions involves neither few nor many, willingness nor unwillingness, neither poverty nor wealth? Rather, if we are to be guided by our previous discussion, it involves some type of knowledge.

292d

Young Socrates: But of course. It is impossible to conclude otherwise.

Stranger: Then, it is now necessary to consider this issue in this way. In which of these constitutions, if any, does it turn out that knowledge of the rule of humanity, perhaps the most important

knowledge and the most difficult to acquire, arises? For we need to see this so that we may behold certain people who must be separated from the sagacious king, people who pretend to be statesmen and who persuade many others of this, but are not statesmen at all.

292e

Young Socrates: Yes, that's what must be done, since our argument has said so.

Stranger: Now, do you think that a large number of people in the city are able to acquire this knowledge?

Young Socrates: No, how could they?

Stranger: Well, in a city of a thousand men, could some hundred, or even fifty, acquire it in an adequate manner?

Young Socrates: On that basis anyway it would be the easiest skill of them all. Indeed, we know that among a thousand men you wouldn't even find that number of first-class draughts players, in relation to the other Greek cities, let alone kings. For based upon the previous argument, it is surely necessary for someone who possesses knowledge of kingship to be referred to as kingly anyway, whether he exercises rule or not.

293a

Stranger: You have remembered that very well. And following on from this, it is necessary, I believe, to look for right rule associated with one particular person, or two, or extremely few, whenever such rule arises.

Young Socrates: Why, of course.

Stranger: Yes. But these people, whether they rule over consenting or unconsenting subjects, whether on the basis of written laws or without written laws, whether they themselves be wealthy or poor, must be regarded as exercising whatever rule they exercise on the basis of a skill according to our present

view. And we do not regard physicians as less than physicians whether they cure us with our consent or without it, whether by cutting, burning or applying some other painful cure, whether they work from written guidelines or without them, whether they are poor or wealthy. In all these cases we declare that they are physicians nonetheless, as long as their directions are based upon a skill. This may involve purifying, or otherwise reducing, or even adding bulk to the body, but once these are directed to some good of our bodies, making them better when they were worse, the individual practitioners preserve the lives of the people they treat. On such a basis I believe, and on no other, shall we propose that this alone is the correct definition of the rule of medicine, and of any other rule whatsoever.

293c

Young Socrates: Exactly.

Stranger: And it must also be the case with constitutions, or so it seems. The one that is pre-eminently correct and is, alone, a constitution is the one in which we would find that the rulers are truly knowledgeable and do not merely seem so, whether they rule based upon laws or in the absence of laws, with their subjects' consent or without it, and whether they themselves be poor or wealthy. None of these should be taken into consideration as a correct criterion.

293d

Young Socrates: Very well.

Stranger: And whether they purify the city for its benefit by putting some people to death or casting them out, or even make it smaller by sending out colonies to somewhere like swarms of bees, or make it bigger by bringing others in from outside and granting them citizenship, as long as they have recourse to knowledge and to justice, preserve it from decline, and to the best of their ability make it better, we should declare that this constitution, in that situation and based upon such criteria, is

the only correct one. Any others we mention should not be referred to as genuine, as they are not really constitutions. No, they are imitations of this one. Those that we call well-ordered have imitated it better, while the others have imitated it quite badly.

293e

Young Socrates: For the most part, stranger, that seems to have been a reasonable description. However, hearing it said that we should rule without laws presented a greater difficulty.

294a

Stranger: You are a little ahead of me with your question, Socrates, for I was about to question you as to whether you would accept all this or had misgivings over some of what had been said. But it is now evident already that you will want us to discuss this issue of the rightness of exercising rule without laws.

Young Socrates: It is inevitable.

Stranger: Now, in a sense it is obvious that law-making belongs to kingship, yet the best course is not for the laws to prevail but for a man who is kingly and possesses wisdom to prevail. Do you know why that is?

Young Socrates: Please tell me. Why?

294b

Stranger: Because a law would never be able to encompass what is best and most just for everyone at the same time in precise terms, and then institute what is best. For the dissimilarities between people and their activities, and the fact that nothing in human affairs ever really comes to rest, prevents any skill whatsoever, in any situation, from proclaiming anything simple that is applicable under all circumstances and for all time. Presumably we are agreed about that?

Young Socrates: Of course.

294c

Stranger: And yet we see the law striving to do just this, much like a stubborn, unlearned person, who allows no one to do anything at variance with his instruction, or to ask any question, even if something new and better occurs to someone at variance with the pronouncement he has instituted.

Young Socrates: This is true. Indeed, the law actually behaves toward each and every one of us in the very manner you describe.

294d

Stranger: Isn't it impossible for something that is entirely simple to be adequately applied to situations that are never simple?

Young Socrates: Quite likely.

Stranger: Then why ever is it necessary to make laws, when the law is never perfectly right? We must find out the reason for this.

Young Socrates: Of course.

Stranger: Don't you also have here, as they do in other cities, courses of instruction for groups of people, relating to the running track or something else, motivated by a desire to win?

Young Socrates: Very much so. There are a lot of them.

Stranger: Come now, let's once again recollect the instructions of the skilled trainers when they are in such positions of authority.

Young Socrates: What sort of instructions?

294e

Stranger: They don't believe it is possible to go into detail about each individual case, and prescribe what is appropriate to

each particular body. Rather, they think it necessary to issue a rough guideline that is beneficial to bodies in general, and applies in most cases.

Young Socrates: Good.

Stranger: Accordingly, they usually assign equal physical exertion to entire crowds, urging them all on at the same time and stopping them all at the same time, whether they are running or wrestling or undertaking any other physical exertions.

Young Socrates: That's what they do.

295a

Stranger: Then we should also presume that the lawmaker who directs this herd of ours in matters of justice, and their dealings with one another, when giving orders to entire crowds of people, will never really be capable of giving every single person precisely what is appropriate.

Young Socrates: That sounds reasonable, anyway.

Stranger: Rather he will, I believe, set down a law for everyone anyway, and it will somehow, for the most part, be roughly appropriate to each individual. These he will issue in writing and in unwritten form, legislating by means of ancestral traditions.

Young Socrates: Correct.

295b

Stranger: Correct indeed, Socrates. For how could anyone ever arrange to sit beside each person, constantly, throughout their life, and instruct them precisely as to what is appropriate for them? In fact, if he were capable of doing this, it is hardly likely, in my view, that anyone who had actually acquired the knowledge of kingship would ever create obstacles for himself by writing down these laws we have referred to.

Young Socrates: Yes, stranger, on the basis of what we are now saying, anyway.

Stranger: And even more so, best of men, on the basis of what we are about to say.

Young Socrates: On what basis is that?

295c

Stranger: On some such basis as this. Let's take the example of a physician, or even a gymnastic trainer, who intends to be abroad and away from those he is looking after for a considerable time, or so he believes. If he thought that the sick people, or those undergoing training, would not remember his instructions, he would want to write down some reminders for them. Is this so?

Socrates: Quite so.

295d

Stranger: And what if he were to come back again, having been abroad for less time than expected? Would he lack the courage to propose alternatives to those written instructions if others turned out to be better for the sick people, because winds or something else from Zeus had somehow arisen unexpectedly in an unusual manner? Would he be stubborn and think that we should not step outside the ancient edicts once they have been set down – either by proposing alternatives himself or by the patient daring to act contrary to the written directions – these being the principles of medicine and health, and whatever is done differently is unhealthy and is not based upon those skills? Or would everything of this sort, at least when it occurs in the case of knowledge and true skill in all subjects, render such ordinances completely and utterly ridiculous?

295e

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: Consider the case of the person who has written laws, or framed unwritten laws, concerning just and unjust behaviour, noble and base practices, good and bad actions, intended for herds of human beings, who are herded in their particular cities based upon the laws of these writers. Is it really not permissible for different instructions, at variance with these, to be issued by the person who has the relevant skill and has written them down, or someone else like him who arrives on the scene? Or would this prohibition, in truth, appear every bit as ridiculous as the previous one?

296a

Young Socrates: Of course it would.

Stranger: Now, do you know the argument that most people present in such a circumstance?

Young Socrates: Nothing relevant comes to mind at the moment.

Stranger: Well, it sounds plausible enough. For they declare that if someone realises that there are laws at variance with those of former generations, but better, he may institute his laws once he has persuaded his own city in each case, but not otherwise.

Young Socrates: What about that? Is it not the right way to proceed?

296b

Stranger: Perhaps, but what if someone were to enforce the better course without using persuasion? Tell me what the name of that enforcement will be. But no, not yet. Answer in relation to the previous example first.

Young Socrates: What are you referring to?

Stranger: Suppose some physician, in proper possession of the relevant skill but without persuading the patient, were to

compel a man, or even a woman or child, to do what is better in contravention of the written precepts. What will be the name of this kind of force? Won't it be far removed from the error we described as 'contrary to the relevant skill' and unhealthy? And the person who suffered such force may justifiably say anything at all about what happened, but may never say that he has suffered unskilled and unhealthy treatment at the hands of the physicians who forced him.

296c

Young Socrates: What you say is perfectly true.

Stranger: What, then, is the error that we refer to as being at variance with the skill of statesmanship? Isn't it baseness, evil and injustice?

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

296d

Stranger: Well, what about those who have been forced, contrary to written edicts and traditions, to perform other actions, more just, better and more noble than those prescribed of old? What, for his part, could a critic of such behaviour say about such use of force, if he is to avoid becoming utterly laughable? He may say anything at all, as the occasion demands, provided he never says that those who were forced to act in that way suffered baseness or evil or injustice at the hands of those who forced them.

Young Socrates: Very true.

296e

Stranger: But are the enforcements just if the person who exerts the force is wealthy, and are they unjust if he is poor? Or if the person, rich or poor, achieves something beneficial, either through persuasion or without persuasion, in conformity with the written laws or at variance with them, the truest definition of proper management of the city in this respect must surely be

this: the one that a wise and good man will employ to manage the affairs of his subjects. Just as a helmsman, being constantly vigilant for the welfare of the ship and its sailors, preserves his fellow sailors not by setting down written edicts, but by presenting his skill as law, so too, based upon the same approach as this, a constitution may become a proper one on account of those who are able to rule in this way, since through their skill they provide a force that is more powerful than the laws. And those who rule intelligently, no matter what they do, avoid error as long as they are vigilant of one major principle: that they always dispense perfect justice based upon reason and skill to the people of the city, and are able, as far as possible, to preserve them and make them better people than they were.

297b

Young Socrates: It is impossible to oppose what you have just said.

Stranger: Nor indeed should anyone contradict those other statements of ours.

Young Socrates: What are you referring to?

Stranger: That no large number of people of any sort would ever be able to acquire this kind of knowledge, and manage the city on the basis of reason. Rather it is in relation to something small, few, even the one, that we must seek for that single proper constitution, and we must designate the others as imitations thereof, and just as we stated a little earlier some imitate it quite well, others quite badly.

297c

Young Socrates: How am I to understand what you have said? In fact, I didn't really understand your earlier statement about imitations either.

Stranger: And, indeed, it would be no trivial matter if someone, having initiated this line of argument, were then to set it aside,

and not even develop it to demonstrate the error that is arising about this issue at the moment.

Young Socrates: What sort of error?

297d

Stranger: We need to look for the kind of thing that is not particularly familiar or easy to see, and we should endeavour to lay hold of it nevertheless. Come on, then. Consider this constitution we have described, the only correct one. You know that the other constitutions must have recourse to the written laws of this one, and be preserved in this way by acting in a manner that is praised nowadays, even though it is not entirely correct to do so.

Young Socrates: What is it that is not entirely correct?

297e

Stranger: The notion that no one in the city should dare to do anything at variance with the laws, and whoever dares to do so should be punished by death and all sorts of extreme penalties. And yet this is entirely proper and appropriate as a second preference, whenever there is a departure from the first, the one we have described just now. So let's explain the manner in which this so-called second-best system has come into being, shall we?

Young Socrates: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: Then let's revert once more to the images, to which it has frequently been necessary to compare the kingly rulers.

Young Socrates: What were they?

Stranger: The noble helmsman, and the physician who is worth as much as a thousand others. Yes, let's see if we can construct some outline based upon the people themselves.

Young Socrates: Of what sort?

298a

Stranger: As follows. Suppose we were all to form the notion that we are suffering outrageous treatment at the hands of these people, for they both, in like manner, preserve any of us whom they wish to preserve, and mistreat any whom they wish to mistreat. They do this by cutting us, burning us, and imposing charges to be paid to them, like a tax, out of which they spend a little or even nothing upon the patient, while they and their members make use of the rest. And what's more, they finally take money from relations, or some enemies of the patient, as payment, and then kill him. The helmsmen, for their part, perform countless other outrages of the same sort. They form conspiracies and abandon us on sea voyages, cause shipwrecks on the oceans and cast us into the sea, and perpetrate other misdeeds.

298b

Stranger: Now, suppose, bearing these afflictions in mind, we were to decide upon a resolution in this regard, no longer to entrust autocratic rule to either of these two professions, neither over slaves nor over free men, a resolution to convene an assembly of ourselves, either of the entire populace or of the wealthy people alone, and to permit private citizens and the various professions to contribute an opinion on sea-faring, and on disease, and on how we should employ drugs and medical instruments in relation to the treatment of the sick, and indeed about the ships themselves, and the nautical equipment we should use on those ships in the face of dangers affecting the voyage itself, from wind and sea or also from encounters with pirates, or even perhaps in a sea battle that has to be fought in longboats against other vessels of that kind, a resolution according to which the opinions of the majority on these matters, whether the advisers be physicians, helmsmen or private citizens, once written down on wooden or stone tablets, or established as unwritten traditional practices, are to be the basis for navigating ships and for treating the sick, now and

forever, for all time.

298e

Young Socrates: You have described some very odd notions.

Stranger: Yes. And rulers of the people are to be appointed annually, drawn either from the wealthy classes or from the general population. And the rulers, once appointed, should rule according to the written edicts in steering the ships and healing the sick.

Young Socrates: This is even more difficult to accept.

299a

Stranger: Then consider what happens after this. For in each case, once the annual term of the rulers has passed, it is necessary to set up a court consisting of men either preselected from the wealthy classes or chosen by lot from the general population. The outgoing rulers must be brought before these people for scrutiny of their conduct, and anyone who wishes may accuse them of not navigating the ships, during their year in office, in accord with the written edicts or in accord with the ancient practices of our ancestors. And the same goes for those who were treating the sick. And the court must decide what penalty or fine should be imposed upon those who are voted down.

299b

Young Socrates: Surely anyone who desires to rule, and is willing to do so under such circumstances, would fully deserve to suffer any penalty at all or be fined any amount whatsoever.

Stranger: And what's more, it will be necessary to institute a law, applicable to everything of this sort, according to which anyone who is found to be investigating helmsmanship, navigation, health, and the truth of medical science in relation to the breaths, or heat and cold, in a manner contrary to the written edicts, and is becoming in any way wise on such

matters, must in the first place be referred to neither as a physician nor as a helmsman, but as a star-gazer or a babbling sophist. Secondly, anyone who is permitted to do so may drag him into some courtroom, charged with corrupting younger people and persuading them to practise helmsmanship and medicine without regard to law, and ruling over ships and sick people in an autocratic manner. And if he is presumed to have persuaded anyone, young or old, to act contrary to the laws that have been written, he must be punished with the most extreme penalties, for none should be wiser than the laws. Nor indeed need anyone be ignorant of medicine and health, or helmsmanship and navigation, for anyone who wishes is permitted to learn the written enactments and the traditional practices that are in place.

299d

Stranger: Well, what if the requirements that we are describing were to apply in the case of these two branches of knowledge, Socrates, and also to generalship, to all forms of hunting whatsoever, and to painting or any part at all of the imitative arts, and to carpentry or to manufacturing as a whole regardless of the kind, or even to agriculture and to the entire skill that is concerned with plants? Or we might also imagine it applying to some kind of horse-keeping that proceeds upon written edicts, to the entire business of herd-minding, to prophecy and every aspect encompassed by service, to draughts-playing, or to the entire science of number, whether pure or as applied to flat surfaces, solids or moving objects. What precisely would the outcome be if all of these were conducted in such a manner as to operate on the basis of written edicts, and not on the basis of the relevant skill?

299e

Young Socrates: It is obvious that all of the skills would completely cease to exist for us, and could never come back into existence again because of this law prohibiting the conduct of

investigation, so that life, which is difficult even now, would at that stage not be worth living at all.

300a

Stranger: What about this? If we were to insist that each of the activities we mentioned be conducted according to the written edicts, and that someone be elected or chosen by lot to oversee those edicts, and yet this person, disregarding the edicts either for the sake of profit or to do some private favour, were to undertake a different course of action contrary thereto, devoid of understanding, wouldn't this evil be even greater than the previous evil?

Young Socrates: That's very true, anyway.

300b

Stranger: Indeed in my view, the laws rest upon considerable experience, and in each case certain advisers have given their counsel in a pleasing manner and have persuaded the populace to adopt them, so anyone who dares to act contrary to these would be perpetrating an even more grievous error, and would be subverting all human action to an even greater extent than any adherence to written laws.

Young Socrates: Yes, that is inevitable.

Stranger: Accordingly, the second-best course for those who enact laws and written edicts on any matter at all is to allow no single person or any group ever to do anything whatsoever that is contrary to those laws.

Young Socrates: Rightly so.

300c

Stranger: Wouldn't these be imitations of the truth, in each case, as received from those who know, and written down insofar as this can be done?

Young Socrates: It must be so.

Stranger: And, indeed, we said, if you remember, that the one who knows, the person who is actually a statesman, will use his skill to perform a great variety of actions relevant to his own activity, disregarding the written edicts whenever an alternative seems better to him, even if it is contrary to his own written directions to other people who are not present.

Young Socrates: Indeed, we said so.

300d

Stranger: Now wouldn't anyone at all, one person or any group of people, who is faced with established laws, and undertakes some different course of action contrary to those laws because such a course is better, be doing to the best of their ability the same thing that a true statesman does?

Young Socrates: Yes, certainly.

Stranger: Now, if they were to do this sort of thing without being knowledgeable, they would endeavour to imitate the truth, but would imitate it extremely badly. Alternatively, if they possessed the relevant skill, this is no longer an imitation, but that itself, the very truest.

Young Socrates: Entirely so, I suppose.

300e

Stranger: And, indeed, from our earlier discussion anyway, there is an agreement between us that no large group of people is capable of acquiring any sort of skill whatsoever.

Young Socrates: That agreement still stands.

Stranger: Therefore, if there is a kingly skill, wealthy people in general, and the entire populace, could not ever acquire this knowledge of statesmanship.

Young Socrates: No, how could they?

301a

Stranger: Then it seems that if such constitutions as these intend, as best they can, to be good imitations of that constitution ruled by a single person possessed of skill, they should never enact anything contrary to the written edicts and traditional practices, once their own laws are in place.

Young Socrates: What you have said is excellent.

Stranger: So, whenever the wealthy people imitate this, we then call a constitution of this sort an aristocracy; and when they pay no heed to the laws, we call it an oligarchy.

Young Socrates: Quite likely.

301b

Stranger: Yes, and whenever a single person, on the basis of the laws, imitates the one who knows, we call him a king, making no distinction by name between the one who exercises sole rule on the basis of the laws by means of knowledge, and the one who does so by means of opinion.

Young Socrates: That's what we are likely to do.

Stranger: Therefore, if a single person who really is knowledgeable happens to rule, he will unequivocally be given the same name, king, and no other. Consequently, the five names of what are now called constitutions become just one.

Young Socrates: So it seems, anyway.

301c

Stranger: And what about a situation in which a single person rules in accord neither with the laws nor the traditions, and pretends to be a person who knows by arguing that it is really necessary to act contrary to the written edicts and do what is best, and some passion and ignorance dominate this particular imitation? Mustn't we surely refer to any such person in that situation as a tyrant?

Young Socrates: Of course.

301d

Stranger: So we are saying that a tyrant arises in this way, a king too, as well as an oligarchy, an aristocracy, and a democracy: from the disgust of humanity with that one sole ruler, and their disbelief that anyone worthy of such rule could ever arise, someone who would be willing and able to rule with knowledge and excellence, dispensing just and sacred ordinances properly to everyone, rather than maltreating, murdering and inflicting evil upon whomsoever he wants, whenever he wants. But if a person such as we are describing were to arise, he would be loved and would dwell there as the benevolent helmsman of what is, strictly speaking, the only correct constitution.

Young Socrates: Of course.

301e

Stranger: But nowadays, when, as we say, a king does not arise in our cities in the way that a single queen bee springs up in a hive of bees – immediately distinct both in body and in soul – we need to gather together and write down our ordinances in pursuit, it seems, of the traces of the truest constitution.

Young Socrates: Quite likely.

302a

Stranger: So, Socrates, need we wonder at the extent of the evil that arises and will continue to arise in such constitutions when they are based upon such a foundation as this – the performance of actions in accord with written edicts and customs not accompanied by knowledge – when it is obvious to everyone that any other skill conducted in this way would ruin its very own productions? Or should we wonder instead at something else, at how naturally strong a city is? Of course, our cities have now been suffering under such behaviour for countless ages, and yet some in particular are stable and are not overthrown. However, on occasion, many of them flounder like

ships and perish, or have perished or shall yet perish, because of the depravity of the helmsmen and the sailors, who have attained a huge level of ignorance in relation to matters of the utmost importance, who are not knowledgeable about matters of statesmanship in any respect, but think that of all branches of knowledge, they have acquired this skill with the utmost clarity in every respect.

302c

Young Socrates: Very true.

Stranger: Now then, which of these improper constitutions is the least difficult to live under, accepting that all of them are difficult, and which is the most oppressive? Is this something we should look at even though it is a secondary consideration compared to what is now before us? And yet, on the whole it is likely that everything we do is motivated by such a consideration.

Young Socrates: We should do as you say, of course.

Stranger: Then we should declare that of those three constitutions, the same one is both exceptionally difficult and easy at the same time.

Young Socrates: How do you mean?

302d

Stranger: I am just saying that monarchy, rule of the few, and rule of the many, were the three constitutions we mentioned at the beginning of the current influx of discussion.

Young Socrates: They were, indeed.

Stranger: Then cutting each one of these in two we would produce six, keeping the correct one separate from these as a seventh.

Young Socrates: How?

Stranger: From monarchy we get the kingly and the tyrannical subdivisions. Then, in turn, from rule not involving many we get aristocracy, which we said has a good reputation, and also oligarchy. And furthermore, in the case of the rule of many, we proposed at the time simply to call it democracy, but now we must also propose a twofold aspect for this.

Young Socrates: In what way? And dividing it on what basis?

302e

Stranger: No differently from the others. Even if its name is already single, there is nevertheless rule according to law and rule contrary to law, both under this constitution and under the others.

Young Socrates: There is, indeed.

Stranger: Now, when we were searching for the right constitution, this division was not useful, as we demonstrated in our previous discussion. However, once we have set that constitution aside, and have proposed that the others are necessary, then the criteria of ruling contrary to law or lawfully, divide each of these constitutions in two.

Young Socrates: So it seems, now that you have presented this argument.

Stranger: Well then, monarchy, when yoked to good written ordinances which we call laws, is the best of the six. But when it is lawless, it is the most oppressive and difficult constitution to live under.

Young Socrates: Quite likely.

303a

Stranger: Then again, just as few are intermediate between one and many, so the rule of the 'not many' should be regarded accordingly as intermediate in both respects. The rule of the many, for its part, is weak in every respect, and in comparison

with the others is capable neither of great good nor of great evil, because public offices therein are distributed in minute subdivisions to many people. Therefore, when all of the constitutions are lawful, this proves to be the worst of them; and when they are all at variance with the law, it is the best; and when all of them lack restraint, the life in a democracy wins out; but when they are orderly, this is the last one you should live in. But life in the first is by far the best, with the exception of the seventh, for we must separate that one from all of the other constitutions, as we would separate a god from human beings.

303b

Young Socrates: It appears that these conclusions follow, and that's how matters stand. So we should do exactly as you say.

303c

Stranger: In that case, we should set aside those who have a common involvement in all these constitutions, except the one based on knowledge, as not being statesmen but seditious influences presiding over vast images. Indeed, they are such themselves, and being the greatest imitators and beguilers, they prove to be the greatest sophists of all the sophists.

Young Socrates: It seems that this epithet is being turned quite rightly against the so-called statesmen.

303d

Stranger: So be it. This has really been like a play for us. Some troop of centaurs and satyrs was coming into view, as we said earlier, and had to be separated from the skill of statesmanship. And it has now been separated in this extremely difficult manner.

Young Socrates: So it appears.

Stranger: But there is something remaining that presents an even greater difficulty than this, since it is more akin to the kingly class, and also harder to understand. Indeed, we appear

to me to be in a similar predicament to those who refine gold.

Young Socrates: How so?

303e

Stranger: Presumably those craftsmen firstly separate out the earth and stones and numerous other substances, and after this, valuable admixtures akin to gold remain – copper and silver, and, on occasion, adamant – which are separable only by fire. Once these have been separated with difficulty, by repeated proving and smelting, we are allowed to behold what we call unadulterated gold alone, just by itself.

Young Socrates: Yes indeed. That is how these processes are said to operate.

304a

Stranger: Well, according to the same account, it seems we too have separated off the others who are alien to, and lacking affinity with, the knowledge of statesmanship, leaving behind the valuable and the kindred. These presumably include generalship, legal affairs, and any rhetoric that cooperates with kingship, persuades people of what is just, and takes a share in steering the affairs of our cities. So, in what way may someone easily separate these off, and display that object of our search, naked and alone, just by itself?

Young Socrates: This is obviously what we should somehow try to do.

Stranger: Then, if it's only a matter of trying, he will be made evident, and we should attempt to reveal him by recourse to music. Tell me something.

Young Socrates: What is it?

304b

Stranger: There is presumably some process of learning music, and a knowledge of manual skills in general?

Young Socrates: There is.

Stranger: What about the further issue of whether it is necessary for us to learn any of these subjects or not? Shall we say that this, for its part, is also knowledge concerning the subjects themselves? What should we say?

Young Socrates: Just that. We should say that it is.

Stranger: Won't we agree that this form of knowledge is different from the previous ones?

Young Socrates: Yes.

304c

Stranger: And should none of these rule any of the others, or should the others rule this one, or should this one manage and rule all of the others?

Young Socrates: This one should rule them.

Stranger: So, are you of the view anyway that, according to us, the knowledge that decides whether we should learn certain subjects or not must rule over whatever knowledge is learned and taught?

Young Socrates: Very much so.

Stranger: And should the knowledge of whether it is necessary to persuade or not, rule over the knowledge of the ability to persuade?

Young Socrates: Of course.

304d

Stranger: So be it. Now, to what form of knowledge shall we assign the ability to persuade crowds and groups by telling them stories, rather than by teaching them?

Young Socrates: I think that this too is obvious. It should be assigned to rhetoric.

Stranger: And the issue of whether we should perform any action whatsoever towards anyone, by means of persuasion or by some use of force, or even leave them entirely undisturbed – with which form of knowledge shall we associate this?

Young Socrates: With the knowledge that rules over the knowledge of persuasion and speech.

Stranger: And that in my view would be nothing other than the power of the statesman.

Young Socrates: Well said.

304e

Stranger: Then it seems we have quickly separated this rhetoric from statesmanship, as being a different form, subservient to it.

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: And what view should we hold, in turn, in relation to a power of the following kind?

Young Socrates: What kind?

Stranger: The power over how we should wage war against those whom we have chosen to fight. Does this involve a skill, or is it devoid of skill?

Young Socrates: But how could we regard it as devoid of skill, when it is a power exercised by generalship, and military science in its entirety?

Stranger: And the power that is able to deliberate knowledgeably on whether we should wage war or withdraw in friendship, should we understand this as different from that, or the same as that?

Young Socrates: To anyone following the previous discussion, it must be different.

305a

Stranger: In that case, shall we declare that it rules over the other one, if in fact we are going to understand it in a manner similar to the previous examples?

Young Socrates: I agree.

Stranger: Now, what exactly shall we undertake to put forward in like manner as mistress of a great and fearsome skill, the art of war in its entirety, unless it really is the skill of kingship?

Young Socrates: None other.

Stranger: So, we shall not propose that the knowledge belonging to the generals is statesmanship since it is subservient.

Young Socrates: Not likely.

305b

Stranger: Come on, then. Let's look at the power possessed by those judges who make their judgements correctly.

Young Socrates: Very well.

Stranger: Now, is this power able to do anything more than take the lawfully established ordinances that it receives from the lawmaker-king, and make judgements on the basis of these by considering which arrangements are just and which are unjust, bringing to bear its own particular excellence by which it would not be prepared to decide upon any issue between people in a manner contrary to the ordinances of the lawmaker, having been corrupted by some bribes, by fear or by lamentations, or any kind of enmity or friendship?

305c

Young Socrates: No, you have pretty well explained how far the function of this particular power extends.

Stranger: In which case we discover that the power possessed by the judges too is not kingship. Rather it is the guardian of the

law and hand-maiden of kingship.

Young Socrates: So it seems, anyway.

Stranger: So, we should recognise, on reviewing all of the kinds of knowledge we have mentioned, that not one of them turns out to be statesmanship. Indeed, kingship, as it really is, should not perform actions itself, but should rule over those who are able to perform actions, recognising the starting point and impetus of the most important matters in the city, with a view also to what is timely and what is not, while others carry out his instructions.

305d

Young Socrates: Rightly so.

Stranger: So, for these reasons, the skills we have just described rule neither over themselves nor one another, but each is concerned with some particular activity of its own, and has acquired a specific name that is appropriate to the particular nature of the activity.

305e

Young Socrates: Yes, that's what they seem to do.

Stranger: But the knowledge that rules over all of these, superintends the laws and all the affairs of the city, and weaves everything together perfectly, has a power that is comprehended in the name belonging to the common factor, and, it seems, may quite properly be referred to as statesmanship.

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: Well, wouldn't we also like to take this further, based upon the example of weaving, now that all the classes relevant to the city have become evident to us?

Young Socrates: Yes, very much so.

306a

Stranger: Then it seems we should state what kind of process the kingly intertwining is, the manner in which it does the intertwining, and the sort of fabric it presents us with.

Young Socrates: Obviously.

Stranger: In that case, it has apparently become necessary to give an exposition of a difficult matter.

Young Socrates: There's no other option anyway. It should be delivered.

Stranger: Indeed, the assertion that a part of excellence is, in a sense, contrary in form to excellence in general is very easily assailed by those who are skilled in verbal disputation by an appeal to the opinions of the majority.

Young Socrates: I do not understand.

306b

Stranger: Then I'll restate it as follows, for I presume you regard courage, for us, to be one part of excellence.

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: Yes. And self-control is different from courage, but this too is one part of that which courage is part of.

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: Then we must dare to pronounce a wondrous doctrine in relation to these.

Young Socrates: Of what sort?

Stranger: That these two, in a certain sense, are very much enemies of one another, and they hold opposing positions in many actual situations.

Young Socrates: How do you mean?

306c

Stranger: The doctrine is not at all familiar, since in fact all the parts of excellence are usually said to be friendly towards one another in some sense.

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: Should we then apply our minds diligently and consider whether this is simply the way it is, or is it more the case that some of these are in opposition to their own kindred in some respect?

Young Socrates: Yes, you should explain how we should consider this issue.

Stranger: It is necessary to investigate all of those circumstances in which we refer to things as good, but nevertheless assign them to two forms opposite to one another.

Young Socrates: Explain this more clearly.

306d

Stranger: Take acuity and speed, whether of body or soul, or in the delivery of a speech. Have you yourself ever praised any of these qualities themselves, either directly or in whatever images of them are provided by musical or pictorial imitation? Or have you ever been present to hear someone else praising them?

Young Socrates: Of course.

Stranger: And can you recall the manner in which they did so in each of these cases?

Young Socrates: Not at all.

Stranger: Now, I wonder if I'll be capable of using words to present to you exactly what is in my mind.

Young Socrates: But why not?

306e

Stranger: You seem to think that this sort of issue is easy. But we really should consider it in those cases in which the skills are opposed. For of course, on many occasions, when we are pleased by the speed, intensity or acuity of numerous actions, be they mental or physical or even vocal, we speak in praise of this by using a single designation, the word 'courage'.

Young Socrates: How so?

307a

Stranger: I am presuming in the first place that we say 'acute and courageous', and we also say 'quick and courageous', and the same goes for 'intense'. And in applying the name that I am uttering in common to all of these natures, we are praising them.

Young Socrates: Yes.

Stranger: Yes. But haven't we, on many occasions, also praised the form of gentleness that occurs in many activities?

Young Socrates: Yes, very much so.

Stranger: Of course, what we say about this is the opposite of what we say about those other qualities.

Young Socrates: In what way?

307b

Stranger: In the sense that in these cases we say 'calm' and 'sound-minded' when admiring activities in the mental realm; then again, 'slow' and 'gentle' when it relates to physical actions; and to 'smooth' and 'deep' in relation to the working of the voice and to all rhythmical motion and any music that makes opportune use of slowness. To all these activities we do not apply the term 'courage', but 'orderliness'.

Young Socrates: Very true.

307c

Stranger: And yet, on the other hand, whenever in our view they both occur inopportunely, we turn around and censure each of them, assigning them to their opposites by the names we use.

Young Socrates: In what way?

Stranger: By saying that those that occur with more acuity than is opportune, or appear too rapid or harsh are violent and manic, while those that are heavier, slower and more gentle are cowardly or sluggish. And we shall find generally, for the most part, that these qualities, along with the sound-minded nature and the courage associated with the opposite qualities, acting as if enmity was their fate, do not mix with one another in activities concerned with such issues. And if we pursue the enquiry further, we shall observe that those who hold them within their souls are at variance with one another too.

307d

Young Socrates: Where do you propose that we observe this?

Stranger: In all the cases we mentioned just now, and probably in many others besides. For on the basis of their own kinship with one set of qualities or the other, I think that they praise one as their own kindred, and censure those belonging to their adversaries as alien, and they adopt highly inimical stances towards one another on numerous issues.

Young Socrates: Very likely.

Stranger: Now, at this stage, the adversity between these forms is mere childishness. However, when it relates to matters of the utmost importance, it turns out to be the most virulent disease of all those that afflict our cities.

307e

Young Socrates: What sort of important matters are you referring to?

Stranger: This is likely to involve the entire planning for living. For of course, those who are especially orderly are always ready to live the quiet life alone, just by themselves, occupying themselves with their own activities. What's more, they interact in this manner with everyone in their home city, and likewise towards foreign cities, being ready to maintain some manner of peace by any means. And because this love of theirs is most inopportune, whenever they behave as they wish to behave, they overlook the fact that they themselves, by maintaining an unmilitary stance, also influence the young towards a similar disposition. Consequently, they are continually beset by adversaries, and it is not long before they themselves, their children and their entire city become slaves rather than a free people, often without them being aware of it.

308a

Young Socrates: What you are describing is harsh, and a terrible predicament indeed.

Stranger: But what about those who are more inclined towards courage? Aren't they constantly drawing their own cities into some war or other because of their excessively strong desire for such a life? And once they have made many powerful enemies, they either utterly destroy their own native land or reduce its people to slaves and underlings of their enemies.

308b

Young Socrates: Yes, that happens too.

Stranger: So how could we deny that in such situations these types always maintain a great deal, indeed a huge amount, of enmity and rivalry towards one another?

Young Socrates: There is no way at all we can deny it.

Stranger: In that case, haven't we found what we were looking for initially – that parts of excellence, of no minor significance, are naturally at variance with one another? And, what's more,

they make those who possess them behave exactly as they do?

Young Socrates: So it seems.

Stranger: Then there is another issue we should take up.

Young Socrates: Of what kind?

308c

Stranger: Does any knowledge concerned with putting things together willingly assemble even the most trivial of its own productions from inferior and serviceable materials combined? Or is it that any knowledge in any situation discards the inferior as best it can, retains what is suitable and serviceable, and, from these, be they similar or dissimilar, constructs a single power and form by bringing them all together into a unity?

Young Socrates: Of course.

308d

Stranger: Then neither will this statesmanship of ours, being natural and true, ever willingly assemble any city from serviceable people and bad people. Rather, it is quite obvious that it will test them first in play, and after that test it will go on to entrust them to those who are capable of educating them, and serving statesmanship in this respect, while for its own part it provides direction and superintendence, just as weaving pays close attention, and directs and superintends the carders – and those who furnish it with whatever it needs for its web – by indicating to each of them the sort of tasks it thinks it is appropriate for them to complete in relation to its own intertwining.

308e

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: It appears to me that kingship does exactly the same thing. Retaining for itself the power of superintendence, it will not permit the lawful educators and nurturers to engage in any practice that does not bring about some characteristic that is

appropriate to the overall blend, and it exhorts them to educate on this basis alone. But those who are unable to share in courage and sound-mindedness, and any other characteristics that are conducive to excellence, but are thrust away by the force of an evil nature into godlessness, violence and injustice, these it casts out through execution, exile, or punishing them with significant loss of status.

309a

Young Socrates: Something of this sort is said to happen anyway.

Stranger: While those who wallow in ignorance and extreme baseness it subjects to the yoke of slavery.

Young Socrates: Quite right.

309b

Stranger: As for the others then, there are some whose natures are amenable to attaining nobility, if they obtain education and will accept being mixed with one another on the basis of a skill. Of these, it regards the ones who are more inclined towards courage as akin to warp threads due to their hard character, while those inclined to orderliness make use of a rich, soft, and, according to this image, a woof-like thread. These two natures, with their opposite inclinations, it attempts to bind and weave together in some such manner, as follows.

Young Socrates: How is it done?

309c

Stranger: First, based upon kinship, it joins together the ever-begotten part of their soul by a divine bond, and then after the divine, it joins the mortal part of them with human bonds.

Young Socrates: Again, what do you mean by this?

Stranger: Whenever opinion that is really true – concerning whatever is noble, just and good, and their opposites – arises in souls, accompanied by steadfastness, I say this is divine, and it

arises in a class that is almost divine.

Young Socrates: It is quite appropriate to say so.

309d

Stranger: Now, are we aware that it belongs to the statesman and the good lawgiver alone, by means of the kingly Muse, to be able to engender this particular opinion in those who have acquired education in the right way, the people we described just now?

Young Socrates: That sounds reasonable.

Stranger: Anyway, Socrates, we would never use the names we are now investigating to refer to anyone who was unable to perform this function.

Young Socrates: No.

Stranger: Well now, won't a courageous soul be made gentle once it has grasped this sort of truth, and, consequently, have more communion with whatever is just, if it so wishes? But if it has no share in this, won't it be more inclined towards a wild nature?

309e

Young Socrates: That is inevitable.

Stranger: But what about the orderly nature? If it shares in these opinions, doesn't it become genuinely self-restrained and wise, by the standard of civic life anyway? But if it does not share in the opinions we are describing, doesn't it quite rightly acquire a reprehensible reputation for folly?

Young Socrates: Entirely so.

Stranger: In that case, shouldn't we declare that this intertwining and binding will never become stable in bad people bound to their own kind, nor in good people bound to bad people, nor would any knowledge ever seriously use it in

such cases?

Young Socrates: Of course.

310a

Stranger: And yet, in those characters born with innate nobility from the very outset, whose upbringing accords with their nature, in these alone it is implanted by the laws, and this indeed is a remedy skilfully applied to them. And just as we said, this bonding together is more divine since it unites parts of excellence that are dissimilar by nature and tend in opposite directions.

Young Socrates: Very true.

Stranger: The remaining bonds are, of course, human, and once this divine bond is in place, it is not particularly difficult either to devise the others, or to implement them once devised.

310b

Young Socrates: How would you do so? And what are they?

Stranger: I mean bonds forged between communities through intermarriage and the community of their children, and those associated with private property exchange and marriage. Indeed, with respect to the procreation of children, most people make such arrangements in an incorrect manner.

Young Socrates: How is that?

Stranger: By the pursuit of wealth and power through such arrangements. But why would anyone seriously regard the censure of this as a worthy discussion topic?

Young Socrates: There is no reason.

310c

Stranger: No. It would be more correct to discuss those who pay attention to the families when making such arrangements, in case they do so in an inappropriate manner.

Young Socrates: Yes, that's reasonable anyway.

Stranger: In fact, they do not act based upon a single correct principle, for they pursue the easiest option available, embrace those who are much like themselves, and have no affection for those who are dissimilar. They assign the utmost significance to their feeling of displeasure.

Young Socrates: In what way?

310d

Stranger: The orderly people seek out their own characteristic, and as best they can they marry those types and bestow their own offspring upon such people again when giving them in marriage. And the courageous type do the very same, by pursuing their own nature, when both of these types should be really doing the exact opposite.

Young Socrates: In what way, and why?

Stranger: Because it is natural that courage, propagated for many generations without being mixed with a sound-minded nature, flourishes powerfully at first, but in the end bursts forth in utter madness.

Young Socrates: That is likely.

310e

Stranger: In contrast, the soul that is too full of moderation, bred over many generations without admixture of daring courage, grows unseasonably dull and ends up totally maimed.

Young Socrates: Yes. That is the likely outcome.

Stranger: Now, I said that these bonds were not difficult to forge once a single opinion about what is noble and good, held by both classes, was in place. For this is the sole function of the kingly weaving process as a whole: never to allow the sound-minded characters to stand apart from the courageous, but to weave them together through unanimity, by granting

privileges or withdrawing them, through reputation and the mutual exchange of sureties. He should then assemble them into what we call a well-woven fabric, and always entrust the public offices in our cities, in common, to these two.

311a

Young Socrates: In what way?

Stranger: When a single official happens to be required, it chooses someone possessing both to take charge, and when a greater number is needed, it combines together a portion of each of the two types. For when the sound-minded characters rule, they are extremely cautious, just and safe, and yet they lack a certain sharp, practical vigour.

Young Socrates: Yes. That's what seems to happen anyway.

311b

Stranger: But the courageous types, by contrast, although inferior to the other types when it comes to justice and caution, still possess exceptional vigour in practical situations. However, it is impossible for all the affairs of our cities, public as well as private, to proceed well without both these qualities being available to them.

Young Socrates: No, how could they?

311c

Stranger: And we may say that this disposition of the courageous and of the sound-minded people, once woven together in an even texture, constitutes the finished fabric of the activity of statesmanship whereby the skill of kingship, having brought these together through like-mindedness and friendship into a common life, and having completed the most magnificent and excellent of all fabrics, embraces all the other people in our cities, slaves and free, by clothing them in this woven web, and rules and superintends thereafter, omitting nothing that renders the city as happy as it belongs to any city

to be.

Socrates: Now, stranger, you have also completed for us a most beautiful account of the kingly man, the statesman.

NOTES

1. Theodorus was from Cyrene, a city in north Africa not far from Siwah, which was home to an oracle to the Egyptian god Ammon (Amun).
2. The conversation between Socrates and Theaetetus took place the previous day, and is depicted in Plato's dialogue, *Theaetetus*. The conversation between Theaetetus and the stranger took place earlier on this same day, and is depicted in Plato's dialogue, *Sophist*.
3. This refers to the sophist, the subject of the previous conversation today. Plato, *Sophist* 221c ff.
4. Lydia and Phrygia were two ancient kingdoms in western Anatolia.
5. This refers to the ponds belonging to the King of Persia.
6. Plato, *Theaetetus* 147c ff.
7. The argument operates by constructing squares and measuring their diagonals.
8. The creature in question is the pig. The pig does not have a split hoof.
9. A pun on the word for 'last' in this sentence confirms that the animal referred to above is indeed the pig.
10. This is a reference to the swineherd.
11. Plato, *Sophist* 227b.
12. Euripides, *Orestes* 986 ff.
13. This is probably a reference to an Athenian official called the King Archon who presided over legal issues concerned with religious matters. He was also responsible for certain sacrifices and ceremonies.

Symposium

ΣΥΜΠΟΣΙΟΝ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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narrator: APOLLODORUS, a constant companion of Socrates; ARISTODEMUS, a follower of Socrates (the actual eyewitness whose account Apollodorus relays) persons in the dialogue:

PHAEDRUS *a friend of Eryximachus*

PAUSANIAS *a lover of Agathon*

ERYXIMACHUS *a physician*

ARISTOPHANES *a comedian*

AGATHON *a tragedian, beloved of Pausanias*

SOCRATES *of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus*

ALCIBIADES *a famous and notorious politician and general*

DIOTIMA *a priestess and teacher, possibly Plato's invention (appears in flashback within Socrates' speech)*

scene: the house of Agathon in Athens, celebrating the victory for his first tragedy

172a

Apollodorus: I do not feel ill-prepared to meet this request of yours. In fact, just the other day I happened to be going up to the city from home in Phalerum when an acquaintance of mine, some way off, saw me from behind and called out in jest, "Man of Phalerum, you, Apollodorus, will you not wait?" So I stopped and waited, and he said,

172b

Companion: "Why, I was actually looking for you just now as I wanted to find out all about the gathering of Agathon,¹ Socrates and Alcibiades,² and the others who were present at the banquet, and about the speeches on love. What were they? For someone who heard about it from Phoenix, the son of Phillip, recounted it to me, and he said that you also knew the story. However, he himself could not come up with anything in detail, so you should tell me the story, for it is only right that you report the words of your friend. But first, tell me, were you yourself present at this gathering or not?"

172c

Apollodorus: I replied, “Whoever reported this quite evidently reported nothing detailed, if you imagine that the gathering you are asking about was so recent that I could have been present.”

Companion: “That is what I thought,” said he.

Apollodorus: “How could you, Glaucon?”³ I asked. “Do you not know that it is many years since Agathon lived in Athens, and it is not yet three years since I began associating with Socrates and made it my business, on a daily basis, to know what he says and does? Before this I was running around on the whim of the moment in the belief that I was achieving something, when, in fact, I was more miserable than anyone, not unlike yourself now, believing that I should engage in every imaginable activity rather than in philosophy.”

173a

Companion: “Do not mock me,” said he. “Just tell me when this gathering happened.”

Apollodorus: And I said, “Well, you and I were still children. It was when Agathon was victorious with his very first tragedy. On the day after, he himself and his chorus conducted the sacrifice for the victory festivities.”

Companion: “So apparently it was quite some time ago,” he said. “Then who told you the story? Was it Socrates himself?”

173b

Apollodorus: “Not at all, by Zeus,” I replied. “It was the same person who told Phoenix, a certain Aristodemus⁴ from Cydathenaeum, a small man who was always barefoot. He was present at the gathering, being foremost among Socrates’ lovers at the time, or so it seems to me. In any case, I did eventually ask Socrates about some aspects of what I had heard from this fellow, and he confirmed for me what I had been told.”

Companion: “Well, why not tell me the story?” he said. “The road into town is certainly well suited for talking and listening as we proceed.”

173c

Apollodorus: So we went on our way as he suggested, discussing the matter at the same time. Consequently, as I said at the outset, I am not ill-prepared. Therefore, since you people also need to be told the story, that is what I must do. In fact, it is extraordinary that whenever I contribute to philosophic discussions myself, or listen to other people, I am utterly delighted, quite apart from my belief in their benefits. But other discussions trouble me, especially those your wealthy money-makers engage in, and I pity you and your companions because you believe you are achieving something when you are achieving nothing. And you, for your part, probably think that I am in a sorry plight, and I believe your opinion is true. But in your case, I do not just believe it, I know it very well.

173d

Companion: Oh, you are always the same, Apollodorus.⁵ Yes, you are constantly denigrating yourself and everyone else. You give me the impression that you regard everyone, apart from Socrates, as wretched, beginning with yourself. Now, I do not know where exactly you got that nickname ‘manic’, yet that is how you always behave in discussions, railing against yourself and everyone else except Socrates.

173e

Apollodorus: Dear friend, of course it is obvious that if I have such an attitude towards myself and yourselves, I must be mad or out of my wits.

Companion: It is not worth arguing over this just now, Apollodorus. Instead, you should do what we asked you to do and no more. So, tell us about the speeches that were made.

Apollodorus: Well, they went somewhat as follows... But no, it is better that I try to tell you the story, from the beginning, in the same way that he told it.

174a

Aristodemus said that he met Socrates, who had bathed and was wearing sandals — two rare activities for the man — and he asked where he was going in such fine array. Socrates said,

Socrates: “To supper at Agathon’s house. In fact, I avoided the victory celebrations yesterday for fear of a crowd, but I agreed to make an appearance today. That is why I have adorned myself, so that beauty may go alongside beauty. What about you? How willing are you to come to supper uninvited?”

174b

Aristodemus told me that he said,

Aristodemus: “I will do whatever you tell me to do.”

Socrates: “Then follow me,” said Socrates, “and we will spoil the proverb by changing it: ‘Good men go of their own accord to the banquets of good men.’⁶ Indeed, Homer runs the risk not only of corrupting this proverb, but of showing contempt for it when he presents Agamemnon as a good man unsurpassed in warfare, and Menelaus as a ‘faint-hearted spearman’;⁷ yet when Agamemnon is conducting a sacrifice and celebrating, he has Menelaus arrive uninvited to the feast,⁸ a lesser man going to the feast of his superior.”

174c

Aristodemus: Aristodemus told me that when he heard this, he said, “Perhaps I too am running a risk here, Socrates, not the one you mentioned but the one depicted by Homer. I am an ordinary fellow going uninvited to the feast of a wise man. So, if you are bringing me with you, you need to decide what excuse you will offer, because I shall not confirm that I am there uninvited. I will say it is at your behest.”

174d

Socrates: As the two of us travel the road, one taking the lead,⁹ he said, “We shall consider what we are going to say. Anyway, let us go.”

Once they had discussed these matters, he told me that they set off. Then Socrates fell behind on the road, somehow directing his mind towards himself, and when Aristodemus waited for him he told him to go on ahead. When he reached Agathon’s house, he found that the door had been left open, and he told me that an amusing incident ensued there. For one of the slaves inside went up to him immediately and brought him to where the others were reclining, and he noted that they were already about to dine. As soon as Agathon saw him, he exclaimed,

174e

Agathon: “Ah, Aristodemus, you have arrived at just the right time to dine with us, and if you are here for any other purpose, defer the matter to another occasion. Yes, I was looking for you yesterday in order to invite you, but you were not to be found. Anyway, are you not bringing Socrates to us?”

Aristodemus: “I turned around,” said he, “and I saw that Socrates was not following me at all, so I explained that I had actually come here to supper with Socrates, at his invitation.”

Agathon: “Yes, it is good of you to do so,” he said, “but where is the man?”

175a

Aristodemus: “He was coming in behind me a moment ago, and I too am wondering where he might be.”

Agathon: “You, slave boy, look for Socrates and bring him in,” said Agathon. Then he said, “Aristodemus, you should recline beside Eryximachus.”

Aristodemus told me that one boy washed his feet so that he could recline, while another boy arrived and announced, “This

fellow Socrates has withdrawn into the neighbour's porch and is standing there." Despite the slave's request he did not want to come in.

Agathon: "Well, that is strange," he said. "Why do you not call him again, and do not let him off this time?"

175b

Aristodemus: Aristodemus told me that he said, "No, do not do that, just leave him. In fact, this is a habit of his. Sometimes he just withdraws, anywhere at all, and stands there. He will be here soon, believe me. Do not disturb him, just leave him."

Agathon: Agathon replied, "If that is what you think, then that is what we should do. You, slaves, entertain the rest of us. You always serve up whatever you please when there is no one in charge of you, so now — and this is something I have never done before — please regard myself and these other men as your invited dinner guests and attend upon us, so that we may have cause to praise you."

175c

After this, they dined, but Socrates did not come in. Agathon frequently gave an order that Socrates be sent for, but Aristodemus would not allow it. Now, it was not long before Socrates arrived, having spent less time there than usual, so they were about halfway through their meal. Then Agathon, who was reclining alone on the last couch, said,

175d

Agathon: "Come here, Socrates, and recline beside me so that, through contact with you, I may enjoy that piece of wisdom that came to you in the porch. Of course you found it and you have it, for you would not have come away without it."

Socrates then sat down and said,

Socrates: "It would be nice, Agathon, if wisdom were the sort of thing that flowed between us, from the fuller to the emptier

once we were in contact with one another, just as water in cups flows through wool from the fuller to the emptier one. Yes, if wisdom is like this too, then I greatly prize my position alongside you, for I believe I will be filled with a copious beautiful wisdom by your side. For my wisdom would be ordinary, even as questionable as a dream, while yours would be resplendent and would hold great promise, young as you are; and this shone forth mightily from you, just the other day, and was put on display before the eyes of more than thirty thousand Greeks.”

175e

Agathon: “Socrates, you are being contemptuous!” said Agathon. “Yet, in due course, you and I shall submit these matters to judgement on the issue of wisdom, resorting to Dionysus¹⁰ as our judge. For the moment, you should turn your attention to your supper.”

After this, he said that once Socrates had reclined and eaten dinner along with the others, and they had poured libations, sung praise to the god and performed the other traditional practices, they turned their attention to drink. He reported that Pausanias¹¹ then initiated an exchange that went somewhat as follows:

176a

Pausanias: “Well, gentlemen,” he said, “what is the least demanding way in which to drink our wine? Now, I am telling you that I really am in a bad way after the drinking yesterday. I need some breathing space, and I think the same also goes for most of you, since you were present yesterday. So let us consider the mildest manner in which we may drink our wine.”

176b

Aristophanes: Then Aristophanes¹² said, “Yes Pausanias, it is good that you mention this issue of introducing some mildness into our drinking habits, for I am one of those who was soaked

in it yesterday.”

He told us that when Eryximachus, the son of Acumenos,¹³ heard them, he said,

Eryximachus: “Yes, that is well expressed, but there is still one person I would like to hear from. Agathon, how is your strength for further drinking?”

Agathon: “No,” said he, “I am not at all strong enough either.”

176c

Eryximachus: “It seems like a godsend for us,” said Eryximachus, “for myself, I mean, and for Aristodemus, Phaedrus¹⁴ and these people, if the rest of you who are well able to drink have now given it up, since we are never up to it. And I will leave Socrates out of the reckoning, for he is able for either approach, so he will be satisfied regardless of what we do. Therefore, since I believe that none of the company is eager to drink a lot of wine, it may be less irksome if I tell you the truth about what drunkenness is actually like. One thing has become obvious to me from my practice of medicine: being drunk is bad for people. And I myself, given the choice, would have no desire to drink to excess, nor would I advise anyone else to do so, especially if they have a hangover from the previous day.”

176d

Phaedrus: Phaedrus of Myrrhinus interrupted and said, “Yes, indeed. For my part, I am well used to taking your advice, especially when you speak on medical matters, and the rest of the company would now be well advised to do the same.”

176e

Well, once they had heard this, they all agreed not to have a drunken party on this occasion, but to drink just for pleasure.

Eryximachus: “Since this has been decided,” said Eryximachus, “and each person is to drink only as much as he wishes and there is to be no compulsion, I propose in addition that we allow

the flute-girl, who has just come in, to take her leave and perform for herself or, if she prefers, for the women of the house. We, for our part, should base today's gathering upon speeches and, if you want, I am willing to propose the sort of speeches we should make."

177a

They all said they wanted this and they demanded that he make the proposal.

Eryximachus: "Well," said Eryximachus, "the source of this proposal is, as Euripides' Melanippe says, 'not my own story'.¹⁵ No, what I am going to relate concerns Phaedrus here. For Phaedrus occasionally makes a complaint to me: 'Is it not awful, Eryximachus,' says he, 'that while there are hymns and praises composed by the poets to some other gods, not even one of our many notable poets has yet composed a single song of praise to Eros, Love, despite that god's venerable age and greatness? Then again consider, if you please, the worthy sophists, the most excellent Prodicus for instance, who wrote prose works praising Heracles and others. Well, that is not so marvellous, but I once came across a book by a wise man in which salt was given amazing praise for its usefulness, and you may have seen lots more subjects of this sort being given praise. This great god has been neglected to such an extent that to this very day no man has ventured to praise him worthily, and yet they turn this sort of thing into a major issue, so I think that Phaedrus is making good points here. Therefore, I wish to make a contribution of my own and to gratify Phaedrus at the same time. What is more, it seems to me appropriate at present that this company honour the god. So, if you share this view we could occupy ourselves quite adequately with speeches. I think that each of us should deliver a speech in praise of Eros, Love, the most beautiful one he can make, proceeding from the right, beginning first with Phaedrus, since he is reclining in the first

position and he is also, at the same time, the father of the proposition.”

177d

Socrates: “No one will cast a vote against you, Eryximachus,” said Socrates. “Nor indeed could I conceivably deny your request, I who declare that I know nothing other than matters of love; nor could Agathon and Pausanias; nor could Aristophanes, whose entire occupation is concerned with Dionysus and Aphrodite; nor could anyone else whom I see here. However, we who are reclining in last place are at a disadvantage. Yet, if those who speak before us speak adequately and beautifully, that should be enough for us. So good luck to Phaedrus. Let him begin and let him sing the praises of Eros.”

178a

So the others all concurred, and they too made the same request that Socrates had made. Now, although Aristodemus did not fully recall everything each person said, nor do I, for my part, remember everything that he told me, nevertheless, I shall recount to you the parts of each person’s speech that I deem most worthy of mention.

First then, as I was saying, he told me that Phaedrus began by making the general point that Eros is a great god, a wonder to men — and even to gods — in all sorts of different ways, but especially in respect of his origin.

178b

Phaedrus: “The god,” said he, “is revered as most ancient and the evidence for this is as follows: Eros does not have any parents, nor are they mentioned by anyone, either poet or common man, and Hesiod¹⁶ says that Chaos arose first, ^{178c} ...and after that broad-bosomed Earth, the steadfast eternal seat of all, and Love.

Phaedrus: “And Acusilaus¹⁷ says, along with Hesiod, that these two, Earth and Love, arose after Chaos. Parmenides¹⁸ too describes his origin: The first of all the gods he devised was Love.

Phaedrus: “Thus, it is accepted by numerous authorities that Love is most ancient. And being most ancient, he is responsible for the greatest benefits we receive. Indeed, I cannot say that there is any greater benefit from one’s youth upwards than a worthy lover, or, for a lover, than a worthy favourite. For the element needed to guide people throughout their lives if they intend to live noble lives is not something that family connections or honours or wealth or anything else can engender so well as Love. What am I referring to? Shame in the case of disgraceful actions, and love of honour in the case of noble actions, for in the absence of those two, it is not possible for a city or an individual to accomplish great and noble deeds. I declare then that a man who is in love and is exposed doing some disgraceful action, or submitting, through cowardice, to disgraceful treatment by another, would not be as concerned at being seen by his father, his companions or anyone else, as much as by his favourite. The same applies to the beloved. We observe that if he is ever detected in some shameful act, he is especially ashamed before his lovers.

178d

Phaedrus: Therefore, if it could be arranged that a city or an army be composed of lovers and their beloveds, what better way might they organise their affairs than by abstaining from all shameful actions and prizing honour in one another’s eyes? And if such people were to fight alongside one another, even a few of them might, to coin a phrase, conquer the whole human race. For a man in love who was breaking rank or throwing away his weapons, would of course much rather be seen by anyone else at all than by his beloved. Instead of that he would

choose to die many times.

179a

Phaedrus: “As for abandoning his favourite or not assisting him in the hour of danger, well there is none so base that Eros could not inspire him towards excellence, to be equal by nature to the very best. Homer says that the god ‘breathes might’ into some of the heroes and this, in truth, is what Eros actually does to those who are in love.¹⁹

179b

Phaedrus: “What is more, lovers alone are willing to die for the beloved, not only men but women too. For us Greeks, the case of Pelias’ daughter, Alcestis, provides enough evidence in support of my claim, since she alone was prepared to die for her husband, and although he had a father and a mother, she, his wife, because of her love, exceeded them in affection to such an extent that she proved them to be strangers to their own son, relatives in name only.²⁰ And once she had performed this deed, her action was regarded as noble, not only by humanity but also by the gods. Accordingly, although many noble deeds are performed by so many people, there is a blessing the gods grant to very few: that their soul be sent back from Hades once more. But they did send her soul back, so delighted were they with her action. Such is the honour the gods bestow, especially upon the zeal and excellence associated with Love.

179d

Phaedrus: But they sent Orpheus,²¹ the son of Oeagrus, out of Hades as a failure, presenting him with a phantom of the woman he came to retrieve, without giving him the woman herself, because they deemed him faint-hearted, a harp player who, unlike Alcestis, did not dare to die for the sake of Love, but contrived to enter Hades whilst still alive. And so, for these reasons they imposed a punishment upon him: that his own death be at the hands of women. They did not grant him the same respect as they gave to Achilles, the son of Thetis, whom

they sent to the Isles of the Blest, because having learned from his mother that he would be slain once he killed Hector, and would return home and die in old age if he did not do so, he made the daring choice, came to the aid of his lover Patroclus, and avenged him, choosing not merely to die for him but to follow his dead lover directly into death. Accordingly, the gods were so hugely delighted that they honoured him in a special way because he granted such importance to his lover.

180a

Phaedrus: And Aeschylus is talking nonsense when he says Achilles was the lover of Patroclus, when he was not only fairer than Patroclus, but fairer also than all the other heroes, and still beardless since he was much younger, as Homer tells us.²² Anyway, the fact is the gods most honour the virtue associated with Love, yet they are more astounded, delighted and generous when the beloved loves the lover than when lovers love their favourites. For a lover is more divine than a favourite; in fact, he is inspired. That is why they honoured Achilles more than Alcestis and sent him to the Isles of the Blest.

180b

Phaedrus: “And so I declare that Love is the most ancient and revered of the gods, and supreme when it comes to the human acquisition of excellence and blessedness in life and after death.”

180c

He told me that this was the sort of speech Phaedrus delivered, and that after Phaedrus there were a number of others that he did not much remember. Leaving them aside, he recounted Pausanias’ speech.

Pausanias: Pausanias said, “Phaedrus, I do not think our proposal to sing the praises of Love purely and simply has been presented in a proper manner. Indeed, if there were only one Eros, all would be well, but it so happens there is not just one.

Since there is not only one Eros, it is better to declare, at the outset, which sort of Love we should praise. Now, I shall try to put this right, firstly by stating which Love we should praise, and then by delivering the praise in a manner worthy of the god. Indeed, we all know that there is no Aphrodite without Love. Therefore, if she were one, Love would be one, but since there are two Aphrodites, there must be two Loves. How could there not be two goddesses? One, the daughter of Uranus, is presumably the elder. She has no mother, and we give her the name 'Heavenly', while the other is younger, born of Zeus and Dione, and we call her 'Common'. So it is also necessary that the Love who works with the latter be called Common, while the other Love be called Heavenly, and it is right to do so.

180e

Pausanias: Now, although it is necessary to praise all the gods, I should also attempt to explain what has been allotted to each of these Loves. For the following principle applies to every action: its performance, in its own right, is neither noble nor disgraceful. For example, what we are doing now, whether we drink, sing or converse, not one of these is noble in itself. No, they turn out like that in action, according to how the action is performed. When performed nobly and rightly it becomes good, and when not performed rightly it becomes disgraceful. This also applies to loving and to Love. Not all Love is noble and worthy of paeans of praise, only that which exhorts us to love in a noble manner.

181b

Pausanias: "Now, the Eros belonging to the Common Aphrodite is truly common. He behaves in whatever manner occurs to him, and he is the Love that the ordinary people experience. And such people, in the first place, love women no less than boys; secondly, they love the bodies of those whom they love, rather than their souls; and finally, with a view only to consummation, they engage with the least intelligent people

they can find, heedless of whether they are acting nobly or not. Consequently, they do whatever occurs to them to do, regardless of whether it is good or not. For he comes from the goddess who is much the younger of the two, and, by birth, she partakes of the female as well as the male. But the Love belonging to the Heavenly goddess firstly partakes not of the female but of the male only, and so this love is the love of boys. Secondly, it is older with no trace of wantonness. Hence, those who are inspired with this Love are inclined towards the male, admiring the one who is naturally stronger and possesses more intelligence.

181d

Pausanias: “Indeed, one may recognise those who are impelled to boy-loving itself, in a pure manner, by this kind of love; for they do not love young boys, but only those who have begun to acquire intelligence, approaching the stage when the beard begins to grow. Yes, I think that those who love them at this stage are equipped to love them throughout their entire life, being with them and sharing a life together, without deceiving them because they trapped them when foolish and young, and making fools of them by leaving them to run off with someone else. There should also be a law against loving mere boys, so that a great deal of effort be not expended upon an unpredictable outcome, for it is unpredictable as to how young boys will turn out, for better or worse, in soul or in body. Now, although good men willingly impose this law upon themselves, it is also necessary to force the common sort of lovers to behave similarly, just as we, to the best of our ability, restrain them from loving free-born women. These are the people who have given rise to the criticism whereby some dare to suggest that it is shameful to gratify lovers. But they say this when they look at these lovers and behold their inappropriate and unjust behaviour, since it would, of course, not be right to censure any action performed in a respectable and lawful manner.

182a

Pausanias: “Furthermore, in other cities, the law relating to love is easy to understand because it has been simply defined. Yet here, and in Sparta, it is complicated. Now, in Elis and Boeotia, and wherever people are not clever speakers, it has been simply decreed that the gratification of lovers is good, and no one, old or young, would suggest that it is a disgrace. This, I presume, is to save them the trouble of trying to persuade the young people when they are such inadequate speakers. On the other hand, in Ionia, and lots of other places where they live under non-Greek rule, the gratification of lovers is regarded as shameful. For among the non-Greeks, this, along with philosophy and love of gymnastics, is shameful because the cities are under tyrannical rule. For I suppose it is not to the advantage of the rulers that enlarged views be engendered among the citizenry, nor strong friendships and associations either, and this is exactly what all these activities, and especially love, are inclined to bring about. Our own local tyrants learned this by experience, for Aristogeiton’s love and Harmodius’ friendship, which became steadfast, brought an end to the tyrants’ regime.²³ Accordingly, wherever it is decreed that it is disgraceful to gratify lovers, the decree is there because of the bad state of those who established it, avarice on the part of the rulers and cowardice on the part of the citizenry. And wherever it is simplistically designated as noble, that is due to indolence in the souls of those who make the decree.

182d

Pausanias: “Here in Athens we have made much better regulations about this, but as I said, they are not easy to understand. Consider the fact that being openly in love is said to be more noble than being secretive, especially in loving the noblest and the most excellent types, even if they are uglier than others. Note also the wonderful encouragement given to a lover by everyone, so it is not as if he is doing something

shameful, and if he captures the beloved we think it noble, and if he does not we think it a shame. And when it comes to his attempts to make a capture, the law grants freedom to the lover to perform extraordinary deeds, and be praised for doing so, deeds which, if anyone else dared perform them in pursuing or wishing to accomplish anything else apart from this, would incur the considerable reproaches of philosophy. Indeed, if anyone who wanted to get money from someone, or to hold high office or a position of power, were prepared to behave as lovers do towards their favourites, including supplications and prayers in their lovers' pleas, swearing oaths, sleeping in doorways, willing to be subjected to slavery of a kind that even a slave would not accept, he would be prevented from adopting such a course of action by friends and foes alike, his enemies censuring him for his fawning and unworthy behaviour, his friends rebuking him and feeling ashamed on his behalf. Yet, when a lover engages in all these activities, he is viewed favourably, and the law allows him to proceed without censure, as if he were engaged in some utterly noble exploit. But the most bizarre aspect is that even when he swears an oath and breaks the terms of that oath, he is forgiven by the gods for, as the multitude declares, an oath of passion is no oath.

183c

Pausanias: “Accordingly, both gods and men have granted total freedom to the lover, as the laws here proclaim, and on this basis someone might presume that in this city, both loving and being friendly to lovers is regarded as entirely noble. But when people see fathers appointing tutors over beloved boys, forbidding them from conversing with their lovers and passing these instructions on to the tutors, when they see the boy's peers or his companions criticising him for such behaviour, and his elders doing nothing to hinder the critics or reproach them for impropriety, anyone who sees this might well conclude, once again, that such behaviour is considered utterly

disgraceful in this city. But I think the situation is as follows. As I said at the outset, it is not a simple matter. The behaviour, just by itself, is neither noble nor disgraceful, rather, if it is conducted nobly it is noble, if conducted disgracefully it is disgraceful. Now, by disgracefully I mean that he gratifies a degenerate person and does so in a degenerate manner; by nobly I mean that he gratifies a worthy person in a noble manner. And that common lover is degenerate. He loves the body rather than the soul, and, indeed, he is not constant, since the object of his love is not constant either. For, as soon as the bloom of the body, the very object of his love, fades, 'he takes wings and departs',²⁴ dishonouring his many words and promises, while he who loves the character of a worthy person remains for life, since he melts into unity with the constant.

184a

Pausanias: Now, our law wishes to test these two lovers well and truly, to gratify the one and avoid the other. So, that is why it encourages lovers to pursue, and favourites to flee, presiding over a contest to test exactly to which of the two types the lovers belong, and to which of the two types the loved ones belong. So, for this reason, firstly, it is regarded as a disgrace for the beloved to be taken quickly, so that there may be some lapse of time, and time is, in general, a good test. Secondly, it is considered a disgrace to be taken by money or political power, either when the beloved is terrified of suffering misfortune and lacks endurance or fails to despise favours that involve money or political outcomes. For none of these seem to be either certain or constant, quite apart from the fact that genuine friendship does not naturally arise from them. So, under our law, there is only one way left, if favourites are to gratify lovers in a noble manner. Indeed, our law is like the one whereby any form of consensual slavery of lovers to their favourites was not regarded as flattery or as blameworthy. Accordingly, there is also only one other consensual form of slavery left that is not

blameworthy: the form concerned with excellence. For among us, if someone is prepared to tend upon another, expecting to be improved through his agency in wisdom or in any other aspect of excellence, this consensual slavery, for its part, is not regarded as disgraceful or as flattery.

184d

Pausanias: Now, it is necessary to combine these two laws together, the one concerned with loving boys and the one about loving wisdom and about excellence in general, if the gratification of a lover by his favourite be noble. For when lover and favourite get together, each having a law, one maintaining that he is justified in serving his obliging favourites in any way at all, the other that he is justified in rendering any services whatsoever to the person who makes him wise and good; the one able to contribute to intelligence and general excellence, the other wishing to acquire education and wisdom in general; then, when these two laws coincide and under those circumstances alone, is it noble for a favourite to gratify a lover, and not otherwise. In this situation, it is no disgrace even to be deceived, but in all other situations this gratification brings shame on a person whether he is deceived or not. For if someone who gratified a lover for the sake of his wealth, on the assumption that he was rich, were deceived and obtained no money because the lover turned out to be poor, this would be disgraceful nonetheless. For a person of this sort seems to show us something about himself, that he would render any service whatsoever to anyone at all for the sake of money, and this is not noble. Now, by the same argument, if someone who gratified a lover, on the assumption that he was good and that he himself was going to be improved by the friendship of the lover, were to be deceived because the fellow turned out to be bad and not possessed of excellence, the deception would be noble nevertheless. For that person, in turn, also seems to have revealed something about himself, that he would be eager to do

anything for anyone for the sake of excellence and becoming a better person, and this, by contrast, is the most noble motivation of all. Thus, any gratification of any kind for the sake of excellence is noble.

185b

Pausanias: This is the Love belonging to the heavenly goddess. It too is heavenly and of great value to the city and the citizenry, compelling the lover himself, and the beloved, to pay much attention to excellence. But all the others belong to the other goddess, the common one. There it is, Phaedrus. This is what I can contribute, extempore, on the subject of Love.”

185c

Pausanias paused. “Yes, the sophists have taught me to use these balanced phrases.”

Then Aristodemus told me that Aristophanes was due to speak next, but it so happened, due to overeating or for some other reason, he had an attack of hiccups and was unable to speak, but he did say to Eryximachus, the physician, who was reclining on the next couch along from him,

Aristophanes: “Eryximachus, it is only right that you put a stop to my hiccup or speak in my place while I stop it myself.”

185d

Eryximachus: Eryximachus replied, “Well, I shall do both, for I am going to speak in your place, and once you have stopped the hiccups, you will speak in mine. While I am speaking, if you hold your breath for a long time the hiccup may stop, otherwise gargle with water. And if it proves to be very persistent, grab anything at all to tickle your nose with, then sneeze. And if you do this once or twice it will stop, even if it is very persistent.”

Aristophanes: “You should get on with your speech,” said Aristophanes, “while I do what you suggest.”

185e

Eryximachus: Eryximachus said, “Well, Pausanias began the speech nicely but did not finish it properly, so it seems that I am the one who must attempt to give it an ending. Indeed, I think he has distinguished the twofold Love nicely. But Love is present not only in the souls of human beings, and not only towards beautiful people. No, it is also towards much else, and is in other things too, in the bodies of all living beings, in whatever grows in the earth and, in a sense, in all of the things that are. I think it is most evident to me from my own profession, medicine, that the god is great and wonderful and extends over everything, over human affairs and divine affairs too.

186a

Eryximachus: “I shall begin by speaking about medicine so that we may give a venerable status to that profession. For the nature of bodies involves this twofold Love, since it is accepted that the health and disease of the body are different and dissimilar, yet what is dissimilar desires and loves dissimilar. So, the Love present in a healthy body is one thing, that present in a sick body is another. And what Pausanias said a moment ago, that it is noble to gratify good people and a disgrace to gratify those who lack restraint, also applies in the case of our bodies themselves. It is noble to gratify what is good and healthy in each body, and we should do so, and the word ‘medically-skilled’ is associated with this process, whereas it is a disgrace to gratify the bad and the diseased, and these should be shown no favour if someone is to exercise this skill. For medical skill may be summed up as the knowledge of the loving disposition of the body towards being filled or emptied, and whoever has a thorough understanding of the noble and shameful Love involved in these is supreme in medical skill, while the person who can effect a transformation so that one love is acquired instead of another, or who knows how to engender it in cases where it is absent but should be present,

and get rid of it when it should not be, he would be a good practitioner. For what is required is the ability to turn the most hostile elements that are in the body into friends that love one another, and the most hostile elements are the complete opposites: cold to heat, bitter to sweet, dry to moist, and everything of that sort. Once he knew how to engender Love and unanimity in these, our progenitor, Asclepius, instituted this profession of ours, according to the poets here whom I believe.

187a

Eryximachus: “Now, I maintain that all medical skill is regulated through this god, and the same goes for gymnastics and agriculture, and it is obvious to anyone who pays it the slightest attention that the same principle applies to music, as Heraclitus perhaps wished to explain, although his words do not express it very well. For he says that the one, when diverging from itself, converges like the harmony of a bow and a lyre.²⁵ But it is highly irrational to state that a harmony diverges, or comes from whatever is still diverging. No, what he probably meant to say was that the harmony arose from the previously divergent high and low notes when they later came into agreement under the influence of musical skill. For there would not, I presume, be harmony from high and low notes that are still diverging, since harmony is concord, and concord is an agreement, and it is impossible that there be agreement from whatever is diverging, as long as they are diverging. Yet it is impossible, by contrast, to harmonise what is diverging and not in agreement, just as rhythm too arises from fast and slow, which were previously divergent and later came to agreement. Here it is music that instils agreement in all these by engendering Love and unanimity between them, just as medicine did in the other instance, and music, for its part, is knowledge of love’s role in relation to harmony and rhythm.

187c

Eryximachus: Now, in the actual establishment of harmony and rhythm there is no difficulty in recognising the role of love, although the twofold Love is not yet present in these cases. But there is indeed a difficulty, and a good artificer is required, once it is necessary that rhythm and harmony be applied to humanity, either by composing them, which is called musical composition, or by making proper use of the melodies and measures that have already been devised, which is called education. For the same argument presents itself once more: that one should gratify the orderly people and do so in such a way that those who are not yet orderly may become more orderly, and one should safeguard the love of these people, and this is the noble one, the Heavenly One, the Love belonging to the Heavenly Muse. The other one, the Common One, belongs to Polyhymnia,²⁶ and this should be applied cautiously wherever it is applied, so that one may reap the pleasure thereof yet engender no lack of restraint. Indeed, it is a major task in our profession to make good use of the desires associated with the culinary arts, so that a person may reap the pleasure without the ill-health. So, in music and in medicine and in everything else both human and divine, as far as practicable, we should be on the lookout for either kind of Love, for both are present.

188a

Eryximachus: “Then too, the structure of the seasons of the year is dominated by these two Loves, and when the opposites just mentioned, heat and cold, dry and moist, attain an orderly Love for one another and acquire a moderate blend and harmony, they come bearing abundance and health to humanity and to the other creatures and plants, and they do no wrong. But whenever the wanton Love dominates the seasons of the year, he wreaks much destruction and much wrong. For plagues are inclined to arise under such conditions, and a variety of other diseases too among both animals and plants, and indeed frost, hail and mildew also arise from the mutual

excesses and disorders of such love-based interactions as these, knowledge of which, associated with the motions of the stars and seasons of the year, is called astronomy. Then again, all sacrifices and the matters entrusted to the seer, both of which involve the intercommunion of gods and of men, are concerned with nothing else except protecting and curing Love. Indeed, all irreverence tends to arise when someone fails to gratify the orderly Love, does not honour him and venerate him in every action, but venerates the other kind in dealing with parents, living or dead, and with the gods.²⁷ Now, in these cases, the task of watching over and curing those who are in love has been assigned to the seer, and this skill is an artificer of friendship between gods and us humans, because it knows which loving relationships of humanity incline us towards obedience and reverence.

188d

Eryximachus: “And so Love, altogether in its totality, possesses great and extensive power. More so, it is all powerful. But the Love associated with what is good, the one perfected in consort with sound-mindedness and justice, both among ourselves and among the gods, this possesses the greatest power, and provides us with all blessedness, enabling us to associate with and be friends with one another and with the gods, our superiors. Now it may well be that in my praise of Eros, I too have omitted a great deal, but that was not my actual intention. Anyway, if I have left anything out it is your job, Aristophanes, to make up the deficiency. Or if you intend to hymn the praises of the god in some other way, then please do so, since your hiccup has now stopped.”

189a

Then Aristodemus told me that Aristophanes took his turn and said,

Aristophanes: “It has stopped indeed, but not before the sneezing remedy was applied to it. So, I am surprised that the body’s good order has a desire for the sort of noises and tickling that sneezing represents, for it stopped the very moment I applied the sneezing remedy.”

189b

Eryximachus: Eryximachus replied, “Dear Aristophanes, watch what you are doing. You are making jokes when you are just about to speak, and although it is open to you to speak in peace, you are forcing me to be on the lookout for anything comical in your speech.”

Aristophanes: Aristophanes responded, with a laugh, “Well spoken, Eryximachus, I will take back anything I have said. But please do not go on the lookout, as I am fearful over what I am about to say, not in case I say something comical, since that would be a profitable outcome, the custom of our comic Muse. No, I am afraid of saying something ridiculous.”

189c

Eryximachus: “Aristophanes,” said he, “you have fired a dart and you think you can make your escape. Well, pay attention. You will have to defend yourself. Speak accordingly, although perhaps I may let you off, if I see fit.”

Aristophanes: “Very well, Eryximachus,” said Aristophanes. “I do intend to speak in a somewhat different manner from yourself and Pausanias, for people seem to be entirely unaware of the power of Love, since if they were aware of this they would provide huge temples and altars for him and perform enormous sacrifices, unlike what happens nowadays where none of this occurs in the case of Love, though he deserves it most of all. Indeed, among the gods he is the best friend to humanity, being the protector of humans and healer of those ills whose cure would constitute an enormous blessing for the human race. So I shall endeavour to explain his power to you, and you may then

be the teachers to everyone else.

189d

Aristophanes: “First, you should learn the nature of humanity and what has happened to that, for in times past our nature was not the same as it is now, but otherwise. For in the first place there were three kinds of human being and not two as nowadays, male and female. No, there was also a third kind, a combination of both genders, but that has disappeared and only its name remains. For at the time, man-woman was a single form and a single name combining both male and female, but it does not exist today, even though the name persists as a term of reproach. Secondly, the shape of each human being, as a whole, was round with its back and sides forming a circle, each having four hands, the same number of legs as hands, and two identical faces situated on its opposite sides, four ears, two sets of genitalia, and you may deduce all the other details from what I have said. It also went about upright, as we do today, moving in either direction as it wished, and when it decided to embark upon a high-speed run, it pushed off with its eight limbs and moved with a rapid circular motion, just like acrobats who set their legs upright and travel around by tumbling with a circular motion.

190b

Aristophanes: “There were these three types, and they were like this because the initial birth of the male was from the sun, the female from the earth, and the one that partakes of both was from the moon, seeing that the moon also partakes of male and female. They themselves were circular and so was their motion, on account of their similarity to their parents. Now, their strength and power was terrifying, and they had such enormous ambitions that they even turned upon the gods, and what Homer says about Ephialtes and Otus relates to these humans: that they attempted to make an ascent to heaven so as to grapple with the gods. Zeus and the other gods deliberated as

to what they should do, and they were at a loss, for they were not in a position to slaughter them and obliterate the race with thunderbolts as they had done to the Giants, since the honours and sacrifices that came from humanity would be obliterated too. Neither could they tolerate this outrageous behaviour.

190c

Aristophanes: “Then Zeus, having considered the matter at length, said, ‘I think I have come up with a device whereby human beings may still exist, and yet their unrestrained behaviour may cease because they will be weaker. For I shall now split each of them in two, and they will immediately be weaker and, at the same time, of more use to us gods because their number will increase. They will walk upright on two legs, but if they still seem to be behaving outrageously and are unwilling to be peaceful, I shall split them in two once more so that they will have to get around by hopping on one leg.’ Once he had said all this, Zeus split the humans in two in the same way that people cut sorb-apples when they are going to preserve them, or cut eggs with hairs. He instructed Apollo to turn the face and the half-neck around towards the cut so that the person, on seeing their own cut, would be more orderly. He also directed him to heal everything else.

190e

Aristophanes: “He turned the face around, drew the skin together from all sides over what is now called the stomach, as though he were tying a purse, and he tied up the single opening in the middle of the stomach to make what they call the navel. He also smoothed out the many other wrinkles, and articulated the chest using an instrument like the one that leather workers use when smoothing out the wrinkles in the leather with a last. A few wrinkles were left around the stomach itself and around the navel as a reminder of that ancient affliction. Now, since our nature had been cut in two, each half, longing for the half of itself, would go back to that, and throwing their arms around

each other, embracing in an effort to grow back together again, they were dying out due to hunger and their general inactivity because they had no wish to do anything without one another. And whenever either of the halves died, the remaining half looked for another and embraced it, either encountering half of a woman, which we now refer to as a woman, or encountering the half of a man. Consequently, they were dying out. But Zeus took pity on them, came up with an alternative arrangement, and repositioned their genitalia to the front, for until then these were on the original outside, and they used to procreate and bear children not upon one another but upon the earth like the cicadas. So, he relocated their parts to the front in this way and thereby brought about generation in one another, by the male in the female.

191c

Aristophanes: “This ensured that if male were to meet female in this embrace, there would be procreation and their race would continue. And, at the same time, if male were to meet male, at least there would be satisfaction from their intercourse. Their search would cease, and they could return to their activities and get on with the rest of their lives. So, love of one another is inherent in humanity from those past ages, reconstituting our ancient nature, endeavouring to make one out of two and cure the defect in the nature of humanity. Therefore, each of us is a counterpart of a human being since we have been cut in half and are like flat-fish, two produced from one, each constantly searching for the particular counterpart of itself. Now, those men who are a section cut from the combined type, the one that was then called a man-woman, they are lovers of women, and most adulterers have arisen from this type. So also have any women who love men and those who are adulteresses.

191e

Aristophanes: Any women who are a section cut from the female type do not pay much heed to men but are more inclined towards women. Female companions have arisen from this type. Those who are sections cut from the male type, pursue males and, while they are still boys, they love men and delight in lying with and being embraced by men, since they are slices of the male. These indeed are the very best of boys and youths, since they are by nature extremely manly. And although some people refer to them as shameless, this is a lie, for they do not behave as they do out of shamelessness. No, it is out of daring, courage and manliness that they cleave to those who are like themselves. There is ample proof of this. In fact, on reaching maturity, it is only this sort who prove themselves as men when it comes to civic affairs. Once they reach manhood they are lovers of boys and they do not, by nature, have an interest in marriage and begetting children, although they are forced into this by convention. Yet they are content to live with one another without marrying. Such a person indeed becomes, in every respect, a lover of boys or a boy who is affectionate to his lover, constantly cleaving to his own kind.

192b

Aristophanes: “Now, whenever the lover of boys, or of anyone else, encounters the very person who is the half of himself, they are wonderfully overcome by friendship, affinity and love, and are scarcely willing to be parted from one another even for a short time. These are the ones who continue with one another throughout their lives, although they would be unable to say what they want from one another for themselves. No one would presume that intercourse is the reason each takes such great eager delight in being with the other. No, the soul of each evidently wants something else which it is unable to express, yet it does have a sense of what it wants, but words fail. And if Hephaestus²⁸ were to stand over them, tools in hand, when they were lying together, and were to ask, ‘Humans, what is it that

you want for yourselves from one another?’ And if they were at a loss and he were to ask again, ‘Well, is this what you desire: to be together with one another as much as possible, so that you do not leave one another, day or night? For if that is what you long for, I am prepared to fuse you into one and weld you together so that you may become one rather than two and, being one, you could both live in communion for the duration of your life. And when you die, even there in Hades you could be one rather than two, having shared a common death. So, take a look and decide whether you desire this and would be content if you got it.’ Having heard all this, we know that there is no one who would turn down the offer, nor indeed would anyone want anything else. Each would literally believe they had heard a description of what they had desired all along: to come together and merge with the beloved and from two become one.

193a

Aristophanes: “So this is the explanation. It is because our original nature was as I described it and we were whole, and the name of the desire and pursuit of the whole is Love. Before that, I say, we were one, but we have now been scattered abroad by the god on account of our behaviour, just as the Arcadians were dispersed by the Spartans.²⁹ So, there is a fear that if we are not well behaved towards the gods we may be sliced in two once more and go about like figures in profile on gravestones, sculpted in relief, sawn through along the line of our noses, mere half dice. That is why every man should encourage piety in relation to the gods in all matters, so that we may avoid that outcome and attain the other, with Love as our leader and commander.

193b

Aristophanes: “Let no one act in opposition to Love; acting in opposition means being hated by the gods, for having befriended the god and being reconciled to him, we shall find and meet up with the favourites that are our own, which is a

rare achievement nowadays. Now, Eryximachus should not interject here, treating my speech as a comedy on the assumption that I am referring to Pausanias and Agathon. Perhaps these men do, in fact, belong to this category and are both male by nature, but what I am saying applies to everyone, both to men and to women, that our human race may attain blessedness provided we bring love to completion. We each find the beloved that is our own and go back to our original nature. So if this is the best arrangement, it must follow that, these days, the arrangement that comes closest to this is the best. This involves meeting a favourite who is naturally congenial to oneself. And the god who is responsible for this deserves our hymns of praise, and that god is Eros who is, at present, our greatest benefactor, leading us to our own, and providing us hereafter with great hope that, once we show due reverence to the gods, he will bring us back to our original nature, heal us and make us happy and blessed.

193d

Aristophanes: “So, Eryximachus,” he said, “this is my speech about Love, quite different from yours. Now, remember what I asked of you. Please do not turn it into a comedy, so that we may also hear what each of the remaining speakers will say — the two remaining speakers in fact, since only Agathon and Socrates remain.”

193e

I am told that Eryximachus said,

Eryximachus: “Well, I will grant your wish since, in my view, your speech was most agreeably delivered. And if I was not a party to the fact that Socrates and Agathon are formidable when it comes to love, I would be quite afraid that they might be stuck for words because of the extent and variety of what has been said already. But now I am confident after all.”

194a

Socrates: Then Socrates said, “Eryximachus, you have contributed admirably to the competition, but if you were in my position, or more to the point, the position I will probably be in once Agathon has delivered a nice speech, you would be even more afraid and every bit as frightened as I am now.”

Agathon: “You want to put a spell on me, Socrates,” said Agathon, “so that I will be in turmoil, thinking that the audience has a strong expectation that I am going to speak well.”

194b

Socrates: “I would be a very forgetful man, Agathon,” said Socrates, “if I were to believe that you would be in turmoil over a handful of people like us, when I saw your confidence and self-assurance as you ascended the stage with your actors, looked that vast audience straight in the eye, all set to present your own words to them, without any concerns whatsoever.”

Agathon: “What is this, Socrates?” said Agathon. “Surely you do not believe that I am so obsessed with the theatre as to be unaware that, to a man of sense, a few intelligent people give more cause for fear than a crowd of stupid ones?”

194c

Socrates: “Agathon,” said he, “I would certainly not be doing the right thing by you if I were to presume any lack of refinement on your part. Rather, I know full well that if you were to meet some people whom you regarded as wise, you would have more respect for them than all the rest. Anyway, we would not be the wise folk, since we were there in the theatre along with the rest of the crowd, but if you did meet up with others who were actually wise, perhaps you would feel ashamed in front of them if you thought you were perhaps doing something disgraceful. Or what do you yourself say?”

Agathon: “What you say is true,” he replied.

Socrates: “Whereas, in front of some crowd, you would not feel ashamed if you thought you were doing something disgraceful, would you?”

194d

Phaedrus: Then he said Phaedrus interrupted saying, “Dear Agathon, if you respond to Socrates it will no longer make the slightest difference to him how our plan unfolds, as long as he has a partner in dialogue, especially someone handsome. Now, I enjoy listening to Socrates in dialogue, but I need to supervise our praises of Eros and ensure that I receive a speech from each one of you. So, once you have both bestowed such praises upon the god, you may at that stage engage in a dialogue.”

194e

Agathon: “Well said, Phaedrus,” retorted Agathon. “Indeed, there is no reason why I should not speak since there will be lots of opportunities for a dialogue with Socrates afterwards.

Agathon: Now, I first propose to explain the manner in which I need to speak and then to deliver my speech. For all the previous speakers, in my opinion, have not sung the praises of the god, but have congratulated humanity on the benefits for which the god is responsible in their case. But no one has stated what sort of god he is who has bestowed these benefits. Now, there is a single correct approach to any praise of anything: one should describe what the subject is like, in the light of the sort of outcome he produces. Accordingly, it is right that we also praise Love, firstly for his characteristics, and then for his benefactions. So although all of the gods are blessed, Love, if such an utterance is allowed and will incur no retribution, is the most blessed of them all, being the most beautiful and the best.

195a

Agathon: “He is the most beautiful because he has the following characteristics. First, he is the youngest of the gods, Phaedrus, and he himself provides strong evidence for this by fleeing from

and evading old age, fast as it obviously is. Anyway, it comes to us faster than we would like. Love naturally hates this and does not go anywhere near it. He constantly keeps company with the young and he himself is young. Indeed, the old saying captures it well, that like is always drawn to like.³⁰ And I agree with Phaedrus on many issues but I do not agree that Eros is more ancient than Cronus and Iapetus. No, I say that he is the youngest of the gods, and ever young, and the ancient events involving the gods, as described by Hesiod³¹ and Parmenides, if these men are speaking the truth, occurred through Necessity and not through Love. For the castrations, imprisonments and the other acts of violence towards one another would not have occurred had Love been among them. Rather, there would have been friendship and peace, as there is now, since Love reigns among the gods.

195c

Agathon: “So, he is young, and as well as being young he is delicate, yet he stands in need of a poet the like of Homer, to portray his delicacy as a god. For Homer declares that Atē is a god and delicate too, or that her feet are delicate anyway, when he says: Yet delicate are her feet for on the ground She speeds not, only on the heads of men.³²

195d

Agathon: “Now, I think he uses a nice piece of evidence to demonstrate her delicacy: the fact that she doesn’t walk on what is hard but upon what is soft. So I shall have recourse to the same proof that Love is delicate, for he walks not upon the earth or upon our skulls which are not particularly soft, but he walks and dwells in the softest things of all. Indeed, he makes his home in the characters and the souls of gods and humans, and what’s more, not just in any random souls. No, if he encounters any soul possessing a hard character he departs, and if it has a soft character he dwells there. Therefore, since he touches the very softest of the very softest, both with his feet

and with his entire being, he must be extremely delicate. Yet, although he is the youngest and the most delicate, he is supple in form as well. For if he was hard, he would not be able to envelop us completely, or to go unnoticed as he first enters into an entire soul and then re-emerges. Strong evidence for his measured and supple character is the gracefulness which, everyone agrees, Love possesses in abundance, for gracelessness and Love are constantly at war with one another.

196a

Agathon: “His beauty of complexion indicates that this god dwells among blossoms, for Love does not settle in a body or soul or anything whatsoever that does not blossom, or has faded, but he does settle and abide in a place of pretty flowers and sweet scent.

196b

Agathon: “Now, that is enough about the beauty of the god, although there is a great deal left to say, but we need to follow this with an account of his excellence. His greatest excellence is that he neither does injustice to god or man, nor suffers injustice at the hands of god or man. For if he experiences anything, he does not experience violence. Violence has no contact with Love, nor does he enact it either, for everyone serves Love willingly in everything, and whatever is willingly agreed by willing participants is just, as ‘the laws, sovereign of the city’³³ declare. In addition to this virtue of justice, he partakes of an abundance of sound-mindedness. For it is agreed that sound-mindedness is mastery over pleasures and desires, and that there is no pleasure stronger than Love, and since they are weaker, they would be mastered by Love, and he would be master and being master over pleasures and desires, Love would be pre-eminently sound-minded. In fact, when it comes to courage not even Ares, the god of war, can stand against Love.³⁴ For Ares does not possess Love, rather Love possesses Ares, Love for Aphrodite that is, according to the story.³⁵ The possessor is

more dominant than the possessed, and since Love dominates the god who is most courageous of them all, he himself would be the most courageous.

196d

Agathon: “Now that we have described the justice, sound-mindedness and courage of the god, what remains is to describe his wisdom, and as far as possible we should endeavour not to be found wanting. And firstly, so that I, for my part, may exalt my own profession just as Eryximachus exalted his, I say that the god is a poet, so wise that he can make a poet of someone else. In any case, whoever is touched by Love becomes a poet even if he had previously been devoid of the Muse.³⁶ So, we may fittingly use this as evidence that, in general, Love is a good poet whose creativity extends to the entire realm of the Muses. For one can neither bestow upon another, nor teach another, what one does not possess or does not know. And, indeed, who would oppose the claim that, in the case of the production of all living creatures, it is by Love’s wisdom that living creatures come into being and grow? Again we know, do we not, that any artificer involved in the other professions, who has this god as his teacher, turns out to be highly regarded and illustrious, while the one whom Love does not touch suffers oblivion? In fact, Apollo discovered archery, medicine and prophecy under the direction of desire and Love, so he too was the pupil of Love, as were the Muses in music, Hephaestus in metal-working, Athena in weaving, and Zeus in the rulership of gods and men. Therefore, these activities of the gods were indeed established once Love had been engendered, Love of beauty obviously, for there is no love of ugliness. Before that, as I said at the outset, endless calamities befell the gods, as we are told, because of the sovereignty of Necessity, but since this god was born, all that is good among gods and men has arisen from their love of beauty.

197c

Agathon: “Accordingly Phaedrus, in my view, Love himself is first, unsurpassed in beauty and goodness, and he is thereafter responsible for other qualities of this sort in others. I am moved to say something in verse, declaring that he is the one who brings Peace to humanity, Stillness and calm to the sea, Rest to the winds and Sleep in the midst of grief.³⁷

197d

Agathon: “He it is who purges us of hostility and fills us with friendship; who makes us come together at gatherings of various kinds; who acts as our leader at festivals, at ceremonies and at sacrifices, bringing gentleness, banishing crudity, bestowing goodwill, withholding ill will, gracious and gentle; to the wise, a vision; to the gods, a marvel; envied by those with no portion of him; prized by those who have a fair share; father of luxury, splendour, ornament, graces, desire and longing; careful of the good, neglectful of the bad; helmsman, defender, ally, and saviour supreme in travail and fear, in yearning and in discourse; the adornment of all of the gods and of humanity; the best and most illustrious leader, whom every man should follow, singing beautiful hymns of praise, sharing in the song he sings, as he enchants the thought of every god and man.

197e

Agathon: “That is my speech, Phaedrus,” he said. “Partly playful, yet serious in due measure, to the best of my ability I lay it before the god.”

198a

According to Aristodemus, everyone who was there applauded when Agathon finished speaking because the young man’s words had been so appropriately spoken, both with respect to himself and with respect to the god. Then Socrates looked at Eryximachus and said,

Socrates: “Dear son of Acumenus, do you still think the fear I felt a while ago was unfounded? Surely what I said at the time

was prophetic, that Agathon was going to speak wonderfully and that I would be at a loss.”

198b

Eryximachus: “To a certain extent,” said Eryximachus. “I think you did state prophetically that Agathon was going to speak well, yet I cannot accept that you could be at a loss.”

Socrates: “Blessed man,” said Socrates, “how can I help but be at a loss, I or anyone else who is about to speak just after the delivery of such a beautiful, variegated speech as that? Although the rest of it was not quite so wonderful, who could avoid being awestruck towards the end on hearing the beauty of its words and phrases? Yet I myself, arriving at the conclusion that I would be unable to say anything that came anywhere near the beauty of his words, almost ran away, and would have fled out of shame had I anywhere to run to. In fact, the speech reminded me of Gorgias, and my predicament was much like what Homer describes.³⁸ I was afraid in the end lest Agathon, in his speech, had sent the head of Gorgias,³⁹ so formidable in speech, against my own speech and would turn me into speechless stone. And I then realised how ridiculous I was when I agreed to take my turn with the rest of you in giving praise to Love and when I said that I was proficient in all that belongs to love,⁴⁰ although, as it turns out, I knew nothing about the process whereby anything at all should be given praise. For I was simple-minded enough to think that one should speak the truth about each of the subjects that are to be praised and, with this as a basis, select the most beautiful aspects thereof and present them in the most appropriate manner possible. And so I had very great expectations that I was going to speak well, on the presumption that I knew the true way to praise anything whatsoever.

198e

Socrates: But it turns out, it seems, that this is not the way to praise anything beautifully. Instead, one should attribute the most exalted and beautiful qualities to the object, whether it possesses them or not, and if it is a lie, well that does not matter. Indeed, it was stated at the outset, it seems, that each of us should merely seem to praise Love rather than actually praising him. That is why, in my view, you marshal every possible expression and attribute it to Love, proclaiming him to be such and such, and the cause of all manner of things, so that he may appear to be unsurpassed in beauty and excellence to people who do not recognise him of course, but surely not to the people who know. And the praise sounds beautiful and impressive too, yet I did not actually realise that this was the way to deliver praise, and in my ignorance, I too agreed to take my turn with you in this process.

199a

Socrates: “So, my tongue made a promise but my mind did not.⁴¹ Let’s bid it farewell then. Indeed, I am not going to give praise in that way, since I would not be able to do so. Yet I am prepared to speak the truth in my own way, if you want me to, rather than competing with your speeches and attracting ridicule. Therefore, you should decide whether a speech of this sort is needed, Phaedrus, whether it is necessary to hear the truth about Love, spoken with whatever sort of words and arrangement of phrases happens to occur to me.”

199b

So Phaedrus agreed, and the others called upon Socrates to speak in whatever manner he himself thought he should speak.

Socrates: “Well, Phaedrus,” said he, “even now, let me put a few little questions to Agathon so that I may agree something with him, and then proceed to speak.”

199c

Phaedrus: “Yes, I will allow it,” said Phaedrus. “Just ask.”

After that, according to Aristodemus, Socrates began somewhat as follows.

Socrates: “Yes, indeed, dear Agathon, I thought you began your speech very nicely by saying that one should first describe the sort of god Eros himself is, and then describe what he does. This introduction pleases me greatly. So come on, since you have described beautifully and magnificently what he is like in general, tell me this too: is Love characterised as love of something or of nothing? Now, I am not asking if Love is love of a father or of a mother, for asking if Love is the love of father or mother would be ridiculous. No, it is as if I were asking about this father in itself. Is the father a father of someone or is he not? Presumably you would tell me, if you wished to answer properly, that the father is the father of a son or a daughter, would you not?”

Agathon: “Very much so,” replied Agathon.

Socrates: “Does not the same go for a mother?”

He also agreed with this.

199e

Socrates: “Well, then,” said Socrates, “answer just a few more questions so that you may understand better what I mean. For if I were to ask, ‘What about this? Is brother just what brother is, a brother of someone, or is he not?’”

He said that he is.

Socrates: “Is he not a brother of a brother or a sister?”

He agreed.

Socrates: “Now,” said he, “try also to describe Love. Is Love the love of nothing or of something?”

Agathon: “He is certainly love of something.”

200a

Socrates: “Well, then,” said Socrates, “keep to yourself the memory of what it is love of, and tell me this: does Love desire that which he is the love of, or does he not?”

Agathon: “He certainly does,” said Agathon.

Socrates: “Does he have what he desires and loves, and then love it, or does he not have it?”

Agathon: “He does not have it, or so it seems, at any rate,” he replied.

200b

Socrates: “Think about this,” said Socrates. “Rather than being likely, is it not necessarily the case that the one who desires, desires that which he lacks, and does not desire that which he does not lack? It seems to me, Agathon, that this is necessarily the case, strikingly so. How does it seem to you?”

Agathon: “That is how it seems to me too,” he replied.

Socrates: “Well said! Now, would someone who is tall wish to be tall, or would someone strong wish to be strong?”

Agathon: “Based upon what has been agreed, that is impossible.”

Socrates: “Because, being what he is, he would presumably not be lacking these qualities.”

Agathon: “What you say is true.”

200c

Socrates: “But suppose someone strong were to wish to be strong, or a fast person to be fast, or a healthy person to be healthy,” said Socrates. “For perhaps someone might believe that in such cases and all similar cases, these people and those like them who have these qualities also desire the very qualities they have. Therefore, I am mentioning this so that we do not get misled. For if you think about it, Agathon, these men must, at

that moment, have each of the qualities they have, regardless of what they wish, and surely no one would desire what he has? So, whenever someone says that I am healthy and I also wish to be healthy, or I am rich and I wish to be rich, and so I desire the very things that I have, we would say to him, 'You, my good man, having acquired wealth, health and strength, also wish to retain them in the future since, at the present moment, you have them regardless of what you wish. So, consider the matter. Whenever you say, "I desire what I already have", you are actually saying "I wish to have in future whatever I already have now".' He would have to agree would he not?"

200e

Aristodemus said that Agathon concurred.

Socrates: Then Socrates said, "Does this not involve loving that which is not immediately available to him, namely the future preservation and presence of these qualities?"

Agathon: "Very much so," he replied.

Socrates: "So, it turns out that this person, and anyone else who has a desire, desires what is not immediately available and not present, something he does not have, something he himself is not and which he therefore lacks. It is for things of this sort that there is desire and Love."

Agathon: "Entirely so," he replied.

201a

Socrates: "Come on, then," said Socrates, "we should recapitulate what has been stated. Is not Love firstly a love of certain things, and secondly of things in which he is lacking?"

Agathon: "Yes," he said.

Socrates: "Now, as well as this, please remember what you said in your speech about what love is of. If you like I will remind you; for I think you said something to the effect that the various

activities were established by the gods through their love of beauty. Is this not what you said?"

Agathon: "Yes, I said that," Agathon responded.

Socrates: "And it is reasonable for you to say so, my friend," said Socrates. "And if this is the case, would not Love be love of beauty and not of ugliness?"

He agreed.

201b

Socrates: "Now, did not we agree that he loves what he lacks and does not have?"

Agathon: "Yes," said he.

Socrates: "Then Love is lacking in beauty and does not have it."

Agathon: "Necessarily," said he.

Socrates: "What about this? Would you say that something that lacks beauty, and has not acquired it, is beautiful?"

Agathon: "Not at all."

Socrates: "So, do you still accept that Love is beautiful, if the things we have said hold good?"

Agathon: And Agathon replied, "Socrates, it looks as if I did not know what I was talking about at the time."

201c

Socrates: "And yet, you did speak beautifully, Agathon," he said. "Please tell me a little more. Do you not think that anything good is also beautiful?"

Agathon: "I do."

Socrates: "So, if Love is lacking in what is beautiful, and anything good is beautiful, then Love would also be lacking in what is good."

Agathon: “I would not be able to argue against you, Socrates,” he said, “so let it be as you say it is.”

Socrates: “On the contrary, beloved Agathon,” said he, “you are unable to argue against the truth, since there is no difficulty in arguing against Socrates.”

201d

Socrates: Socrates said: “I am going to leave you be at this stage, and I shall attempt instead to recount to you a discourse concerning Love that I once heard from a woman of Mantinea, Diotima. She was wise in these matters and in many others, and on one occasion she secured a ten-year postponement of the plague for the people of Athens when they performed their sacrifices. She is the one who taught me about all that belongs to love, and the discourse is hers. Based upon what has been agreed by Agathon and myself, I shall attempt to recount it on my own, in whatever way I can. Now, as you explained, Agathon, what I should do first is describe Love himself, what he is and how he is characterised, and then go on to describe his works. So, I think it is easiest to recount the manner in which the stranger from Mantinea went about it at the time, since she questioned me closely. I used different words, but what I said to her was much the same as what Agathon said to me just now, that Love is a great god and it is love of whatever is beautiful. She then refuted me with the very arguments with which I refuted Agathon, showing that according to my own argument Love was neither beautiful nor good.

201e

Socrates: “So I said, ‘Diotima, what are you saying? Is Love, in fact, ugly and bad?’

Diotima: She replied, ‘Show some respect, or do you think that something that is not beautiful would necessarily be ugly?’

202a

Socrates: ‘Very much so.’

Diotima: ‘And would someone who is not wise be ignorant? Or do you not realise that there is something in between wisdom and ignorance?’

Socrates: ‘What is that?’

Diotima: ‘Are you not aware,’ said she, ‘that holding right opinions, even without being able to give an account, does not involve knowing, for how could something that is unreasoned be knowledge? Neither is it ignorance, for how could something that corresponds with what is, be ignorance? And surely right opinion is something of this sort, between understanding and ignorance.’

Socrates: ‘What you say is true,’ I replied.

202b

Diotima: ‘Then do not insist that what is not beautiful must be ugly or that what is not good must be bad. And in the case of Love, when you yourself agree that he is neither good nor beautiful, do not presume further that he must be ugly and bad, but something between these two,’ said she.

Socrates: ‘And yet,’ said I, ‘certainly it is agreed by everyone that he is a great god.’

Diotima: ‘Do you mean by everyone who does not know him, or also by those who know him?’ she asked.

Socrates: ‘By all of them,’ said I.

202c

Diotima: She laughed and asked, ‘And how, Socrates, could those who maintain that he is not even a god agree that he is a great god?’

Socrates: ‘Who are these people?’ I asked.

Diotima: ‘You are one of them,’ said she, ‘and I am another.’

Socrates: ‘How can you say this?’ I asked.

Diotima: ‘Quite easily,’ she replied. ‘Yes. Tell me, do you not agree that all gods are happy and beautiful? Or would you dare to deny that any of the gods are beautiful and blessed?’

Socrates: ‘By Zeus, I would not,’ said I.

Diotima: ‘And do you agree that the blessed are those who have acquired what is good and beautiful?’

Socrates: ‘Entirely so.’

202d

Diotima: ‘And yet you have agreed that Love, because of a lack of whatever is good and beautiful, desires whatever he lacks.’

Socrates: ‘Yes, I have agreed.’

Diotima: ‘So, how could someone with no portion of what is beautiful and good be a god?’

Socrates: ‘In no way at all, as it seems.’

Diotima: ‘Can you now see’, she asked, ‘that you yourself do not regard Love as a god?’

Socrates: ‘What can Love be then?’ I asked. ‘Is he a mortal?’

Diotima: ‘Not in the least.’

Socrates: ‘Then what is he?’

Diotima: ‘As in the previous examples,’ said she, ‘in between mortal and immortal.’

Socrates: ‘What then, Diotima?’

202e

Diotima: ‘A great spirit, Socrates. In fact, the entire realm of spirit lies between the divine and the mortal.’

Socrates: ‘What power does he have?’ I asked.

Diotima: ‘The power of interpreting and conveying entreaties and sacrifices from humanity to the gods, and any commands

from the gods to humanity, and their favours too in return for our sacrifices. This realm lies between these two, filling up that space so that it binds the whole together with itself. Through this proceeds all prophecy, the craft of the priests concerning sacrifices, rituals and hymns, and all divination and enchantment. God does not mix with humanity, so any interaction and converse between gods and humanity, asleep or awake, is through spirit. He who is wise in such matters is a man of spirit, while he who is wise in anything else, based upon some expertise or dexterity, is base. Many and varied are these spirits, and Love is, indeed, among them.'

203a

Socrates: 'From what father and mother was he born?' I asked.

Diotima: 'The story is somewhat lengthy but I will tell you nevertheless,' she replied. 'When Aphrodite was born, the gods held a feast, and among them was Resource, the son of Cunning. Once they had dined, Poverty arrived, begging as she usually did at such festivities, and she hung about the doorways. Resource was drunk on nectar — indeed there was no wine in those days — so he went out into the garden of Zeus, was overcome with heaviness and fell asleep. Now, Poverty, because she herself was devoid of resource, contriving to have a child by Resource, lies down beside him, thus conceiving Love. That is why Love is also a follower and attendant of Aphrodite. Begotten at her birthday festivities, he is a lover by nature, drawn to beauty because Aphrodite is beautiful.

203c

Diotima: 'Now, since Love is the son of Resource and Poverty, he finds himself in the following circumstances. Firstly, he is always poor and far from being delicate and beautiful as so many people believe; rather he is hard, squalid, barefoot and homeless, always sleeping on the ground without covers, lying in the open air in doorways or on the streets, possessed of his

mother's nature, dwelling ever alongside lack. Then again, because of his father, he has designs upon anything beautiful and good; he is courageous, energetic and intense, a formidable hunter, always devising some schemes. He desires understanding and is resourceful in obtaining it. He is a life-long lover of wisdom,⁴² a clever enchanter, sorcerer, and sophist, by nature neither immortal nor mortal. Rather, on the self-same day he thrives and is alive at one moment whenever he is well resourced, but the next moment he is dying; yet he comes back to life again because of his father's nature. Whatever resources he obtains are constantly slipping away, and so he is neither devoid of resources nor wealthy, and what is more he is midway between wisdom and ignorance.

203e

Diotima: 'This is how matters stand. None of the gods love wisdom, or desire to become wise, for they are wise already. Nor does anyone else who is wise, love wisdom. Neither do the ignorant, for their part, love wisdom or desire to become wise. Indeed, that is the very problem with ignorance: that someone who is neither noble nor good nor intelligent thinks that he himself has enough nobility, goodness and intelligence, and a person who does not think he lacks anything has no desire for what he thinks he has.'

204a

Socrates: 'Who then are those who love wisdom, Diotima,' I asked, 'if they are neither the wise nor the ignorant?'

Diotima: 'Surely this is obvious by now, even to a child,' said she. 'It's those who are in between these two, and Love would be among them. For wisdom is one of the supreme beauties, and Love is love of beauty, so Love necessarily loves wisdom, and since it loves wisdom it is between wisdom and ignorance. His origin explains why he is like this too, for his father is wise and well resourced, while his mother is unwise and ill-resourced.'

Such then is the nature of this spirit, beloved Socrates, and it is no wonder you thought that Love was as you said he was. And you thought, and what you are saying seems to prove this, that Love is what is loved rather than that which loves. That is presumably why Love seemed utterly beautiful to you. And, in fact, the object of love is what is really beautiful, delicate, perfect and revered, whereas that which loves has a different character, of the kind I have just described.'

204c

Socrates: I then said, 'So be it, dear stranger, for you have explained this very well. Since Love is like this, what use is he to humanity?'

204d

Diotima: 'That, Socrates,' said she, 'is what I shall endeavour to teach you next. Now, although Love is like this and has come into being in this way, he is nevertheless, as you agree, the love of what is beautiful. So, what if someone were to ask us, "Socrates and Diotima, in what sense is Love a love of what is beautiful? Or to put it more clearly, if a person who loves has love of what is beautiful, what does he love?"'

Socrates: 'To obtain them,' said I.

Diotima: 'But your answer raises a further question of the following kind,' she said. 'What will someone obtain, should he obtain what is beautiful?'

Socrates: 'That', said I, 'is a question to which I am, as yet, unable to give an immediate answer.'

204e

Diotima: 'Well,' said she, 'if someone were to substitute the word beauty with the word good, and ask you, "Come on, Socrates, what does a person who loves whatever is good, love?"'

Socrates: 'To obtain it,' I replied.

Diotima: ‘And what will someone obtain, should he obtain whatever is good?’

Socrates: ‘I am in a better position to answer this,’ said I. ‘He will be happy.’

205a

Diotima: ‘Yes,’ she said. ‘It is through the acquisition of whatever is good that those who are happy, are happy. And is it the case that there is no need to ask further why someone who wishes to be happy, wishes to be so? Your answer seems to be final.’

Socrates: ‘What you say is true,’ said I.

Diotima: ‘Now, do you think this wish, and this love, is common to all people, and that everyone always wishes that whatever is good be his, or what would you say?’

Socrates: ‘Just that,’ I replied. ‘This wish is common to all.’

205b

Diotima: ‘In that case, Socrates,’ she asked, ‘since everyone loves the same thing all the time, why do we not also say that everyone loves rather than saying that there are some who love and some who do not?’

Socrates: ‘I too wonder about this,’ said I.

Diotima: ‘There is nothing to wonder about,’ said she, ‘for we actually separate out a form of Love and we give it a name, assigning to it the name of the whole, Love, and we use other names for the other forms of Love.’

Socrates: ‘Can you give an example?’ said I.

205c

Diotima: ‘For instance, you are aware that there are varieties of composition, for the cause by which anything whatsoever passes from non-being into being is composition in general. And so anything that is wrought by any skill whatsoever is a

composition, and the artificers thereof are all poets.’⁴³

Socrates: ‘What you say is true.’

Diotima: ‘Nevertheless,’ said she, ‘you know that they are not all called composers. They have other names, since one portion has been distinguished from composition in its entirety, namely the part concerned with music and metre, and this has been referred to by the name of the whole, for this portion alone is called composition, and only those who hold to this aspect of composition are called composers.’

Socrates: ‘What you say is true,’ said I.

205d

Diotima: ‘Well, the same consideration also applies to Love. To sum up, any desire in anyone for whatever is good, and for being happy, is Love, “great and treacherous”. But those who have recourse to him in a variety of other ways, through money-making, or their love of gymnastics, or of wisdom, are not said to demonstrate love or to be lovers, while those who have recourse to one particular form, and apply themselves to that, adopt the name of the whole, Love, and are said to demonstrate love and to be lovers.’

Socrates: ‘That is probably true,’ said I.

205e

Diotima: ‘And although a story is told, according to which those who demonstrate Love are seeking the other half of themselves, my own account declares that love is neither of a half nor of a whole, unless these somehow happen to be good, my friend, since people are willing to have even their own feet and hands cut off, if they think these are detrimental to themselves. Indeed, in my view, people do not cling to their possessions except in cases where a person refers to the good as familiar, and as his own, and to the bad as alien, since there is nothing else that people love except the good. Or do you think there is?’

Socrates: ‘By Zeus, I do not,’ said I.

206a

Diotima: ‘Well, then,’ said she, ‘may we declare, without reservation, that people love the good?’

Socrates: ‘Yes,’ I replied.

Diotima: ‘What about this: should we not also propose that what they love is to have the good?’

Socrates: ‘We should also propose that,’ said I.

Diotima: ‘And indeed not just to have it,’ said she, ‘but to have it always?’

Socrates: ‘That too,’ I replied.

Diotima: ‘Then to sum up, love is the love of having the good always.’

Socrates: ‘What you say is very true,’ said I.

206b

Diotima: ‘Now, since this is what Love always is,’ said she, ‘through what activity should those who pursue its object pursue it, if their eagerness and exertion is to be referred to as Love? What exactly is this act? Can you say?’

Socrates: ‘No, I cannot, Diotima. If I could, I would not be in awe of you and your wisdom, your constant visitor, intent on learning these very things from you.’

Diotima: ‘Then I shall tell you,’ said she. ‘It is the act of bringing forth in beauty, both in respect of the body and in respect of the soul.’

206c

Socrates: ‘Some prophetic power is needed to appreciate exactly what you mean,’ I said. ‘I do not understand.’

Diotima: ‘Then,’ said she, ‘I shall speak with greater clarity. Indeed, Socrates,’ said she, ‘all people are pregnant either in respect of the body or in respect of the soul, and once we attain a certain age our nature has a desire to bring forth. But it is not able to bring forth in ugliness, only in beauty. In fact, the intercourse of man and of woman is a bringing forth. This is something divine and, among mortals, this pregnancy and begetting is an immortal element within them. But this cannot arise in anything unsuitable, and ugliness is ill-suited to all that is divine, while beauty suits it well. So, for coming into being, Beauty is Destiny and the goddess of childbirth too. That’s why whenever the pregnant one associates with beauty, it becomes gracious and, being gladdened, it melts, brings forth and begets. Yet whenever it associates with ugliness, it becomes sullen and, being pained, it contracts, turns away, shrinks back and does not beget; rather it holds onto its conception and carries it with difficulty. And so the pregnant one, who by now is swollen and ripe, becomes highly emotional when in the vicinity of the beautiful because it is freed of its great travail by the bearer of beauty. For love, Socrates, is not love of the beautiful as you seem to think.’

206e

Socrates: ‘What is it then?’

Diotima: ‘It is love of the begetting and the bringing forth in beauty.’

Socrates: ‘Let it be so,’ said I.

Diotima: ‘Very much so,’ she said. ‘But why ever is it a love of begetting? Because for a mortal creature begetting is eternal and immortal, and from what we have agreed, since love is of the everlasting possession of the good, it is necessary to desire immortality along with the good. So, based upon this argument, love is, of necessity, also of immortality.’”

207a

Socrates: “Now, she taught me all this on the occasions when she presented discourses about love, and she once asked me, ‘Socrates, what do you think is the cause of this love and this desire? Have you not noticed that all animals are afflicted dreadfully when they have a desire to beget? Whether they are winged or go by foot, they are all laid low and afflicted by love, firstly for intercourse with one another, and then for the nurture of their offspring. Even the weakest are ready to do battle against the very strongest on behalf of their offspring and to die for them, being racked with hunger themselves so as to feed them, and prepared to do anything else at all. You might think that human beings do this based upon their reasoned calculation,’ she said, ‘but why are animals afflicted in this way by love? Do you have something to say?’

207c

Socrates: “And I said, once more, that I did not know, and she said, ‘How will you ever become expert in whatever belongs to love if you do not reflect on these questions?’

Socrates: ‘Well, as I just said, that is the very reason I have come to you, Diotima. I realise that I need teachers. So, tell me the reason for this too, and for whatever else is involved in all that belongs to love.’

207d

Diotima: ‘Well,’ she said, ‘if you accept that by nature love is for what we have so often agreed it is for, this should be no surprise. The same argument applies in both cases. The mortal nature seeks, as best it can, to exist forever and to be immortal. And this is possible in only one way, through generation, because that continually leaves behind another new creature in place of the old. Since, even for the span of time that each individual creature is said to be alive and to be the same, for example a person is referred to as the same creature from childhood until old age, even though it never actually remains

the same in itself, nevertheless it is referred to as the same. Rather, some parts are continually becoming new, while others are being lost. This applies to hair, flesh, bone, blood, indeed to the entire body, and not just to the body. For in the case of the soul too, its tendencies, habits, opinions, desires, pleasures, pains, fears, each of these is present to each of us, but they are never the same. Rather, as some of them are arising in us others are being lost. Much stranger even than these instances are the various things that we know. Not only are some arising in us while others are being lost, so that based on the various things that we know we are never the same, but the same thing also happens to every single thing that we know. So, what we call practice exists on the presumption that there is a shedding of knowledge, for forgetting is a departure of knowledge, while practice preserves the knowledge by engendering a new memory within us once more in place of what is leaving, so that the knowledge seems to be the same. Indeed, this is how anything mortal is preserved, not by being the same in every respect, like the divine, but by leaving behind something else, something new, something that is like what it was, in place of whatever is being lost through its old age. This, Socrates,' she said, 'is the mechanism by which the mortal partakes of immortality, both in body and in every other respect. The immortal does so in a different way. So, do not be surprised that every creature naturally reveres its own offspring, since this eagerness and love attends upon everything for the sake of immortality.'"

208b

Socrates: "And when I had heard this account I was amazed, and I exclaimed, 'Is this so, wisest Diotima? Is this the truth of the matter?'"

208c

Diotima: "And just like an accomplished sophist, she replied, 'Doubt it not, Socrates, since even among humans, if you'd care

to look at their love of honour, you would be astonished at their irrationality in the cases I have described unless you keep in mind, on reflection, the terrible state they get into over their love of being renowned and of “storing up immortal fame for all time.” On account of this, they are prepared to risk any dangers at all, even more than they would for their own children, to spend their money, endure any hardship whatsoever and even to die for the sake of this. Do you really think Alcestis would have died in place of Admetus, or that Achilles would have followed Patroclus into death, or that your own Codrus⁴⁴ would have died in defence of the kingdom of his children, unless they believed there would be immortal memory of their own excellence, a memory we now possess? Far from it,’ she said. ‘No, I believe they all do all these deeds for the sake of immortal excellence and a glorious reputation of that sort, and the better people do this to a greater extent, because they love immortality.

208e

Diotima: ‘Now,’ she said, ‘those who are pregnant in their bodies are more inclined towards women and are affected by love in this way, believing that they will secure immortality, fame and happiness for themselves for all time by begetting children. While as far as soul is concerned,’ said she, ‘those who are pregnant in their souls, even more than in their bodies, conceive and bring forth what belongs to the soul. So, what belongs to the soul? Understanding and excellence in general are indeed begotten by all the poets and by any artificers who are regarded as creative. Yet the most extensive and most beautiful understanding, by far, is the setting in order of our cities and our households, and its name is sound-mindedness and justice. What is more, when someone is pregnant with these in soul from a young age, being divine, and reaching an age where he develops a desire to bring forth and beget, he then, I presume, goes around searching for the beauty in which he may

beget, for he will never beget in ugliness. Since the person is pregnant, he welcomes beautiful bodies rather than ugly ones, and should he also encounter a beautiful, noble and well-developed soul, he welcomes the twofold combination all the more. And towards this person he is immediately well resourced with words about excellence, and what a good man should be like, and how he should behave, and he sets about educating him. For being in contact with the beautiful one, and consorting therewith, what was conceived in times past is brought forth and begotten when the beautiful one is present, and when he is absent but remembered. And he joins with that person in the shared nurture of what they have begotten, so that such people maintain a much greater communion with one another, and a more constant friendship than children would afford, since their communion involves children who are more beautiful and more immortal. And everyone would prefer to have such children as these rather than the human kind, and looking at Homer and Hesiod and the other good poets, they envy the offspring of themselves that these poets leave behind, which furnish the poets with immortal glory and fame, since that is what the offspring itself is like. Or if you prefer,' said she, 'look at the sort of children Lycurgus⁴⁵ left behind him in Sparta, saviours of Sparta and, in a sense, of Greece. Solon⁴⁶ too is revered among yourselves as the begetter of your laws, as are other men in many other places, among Greeks and non-Greeks, for their display of so many noble deeds, and for begetting excellence of every kind. Many shrines have already been established for them because they had such children as these, but this has never yet happened because of human children.

209e

Diotima: 'Now, Socrates, you too could probably be initiated into all that belongs to love, yet I do not know if you are able for the final initiation and vision which is the aim of all this, provided the aspirant proceeds aright. So, I will tell you,' said

she, 'and my eagerness shall not be found wanting. Try to follow me, if you can.

210a

Diotima: 'Indeed,' said she, 'whoever embarks upon this endeavour in the correct manner should begin, whilst young, by approaching beautiful bodies. Firstly, if his guide guides him aright, he should love a single body, beget beautiful words with that, and then recognise that the beauty in any body whatsoever is akin to that in any other body, and if he must pursue beauty associated with form, it would be most irrational not to regard the beauty in all the bodies as one and the same. Once he has recognised this, he should become a lover of all beautiful bodies and relax his intensity towards a particular one, despising it and regarding it as a trifle. After this, he should regard the beauty in souls as more honourable than the beauty in bodies, so it would be quite enough for him if someone fair of soul had even a little physical bloom. He would love that person, care for him, and bring forth and seek out such words as make young people better, so that he is compelled, in turn, to behold the beauty present in activities and in laws, and see that it is all completely interrelated, and come to regard beauty of body as something trivial. After the activities, he should be led on to knowledge, so that he might then see the beauty of knowledge, and looking then towards the vast beauty, be no longer delighted, like a slave in base and trivial servitude, by the beauty of some particular boy or man, or by a single activity. Turning instead to the open sea of beauty and contemplating that, he brings forth beautiful and magnificent words and reflections aplenty, in an ungrudging love of wisdom, until, strengthened and developed in that, he recognises a single knowledge of this kind, knowledge of a beauty I shall now describe.

210e

Diotima: ‘Try’, said she, ‘to give me your fullest attention. For whoever has been instructed as far as this concerning love, contemplating the beauties properly and in due order, approaching then the final objective of all that belongs to love, will suddenly behold a beauty, wondrous in nature, for whose sake, Socrates, all his previous toils were undertaken; a beauty that first of all always is, and neither comes into being nor passes away, neither grows nor decays; a beauty that is not beautiful in one respect and ugly in another, nor beautiful at one moment and not so the next, nor beautiful in relation to one thing but ugly in relation to another, nor beautiful in this place but ugly in that, because it is beautiful to some people but ugly to others; nor again will beauty appear to him like some face or hands or anything at all that partakes of body, nor like some word, or some knowledge, nor as being located in something different, such as an animal or in earth or in heaven or in anything else, but rather as being always just by itself, of one form with itself, while all the other beauties share in this, in such a manner that somehow, in spite of their coming into being and passing away, this beauty undergoes neither increase nor decrease, nor is it affected at all. So, whenever someone, by being a lover of youths in the correct manner, ascends upwards from those beauties and begins to get clear sight of that beauty, he would almost be in touch with the final goal.

211c

Diotima: ‘This, then, is indeed the correct manner of embarking upon whatever belongs to love or of being guided by someone else: beginning from these beauties to ascend ever upwards for the sake of that beauty, using these beauties as steps of ascent, from one to two, and from two to all beautiful bodies, and from beautiful bodies to beautiful activities, and from the activities to beautiful teachings, and from the teachings, finally to that teaching which is the teaching of that beauty itself and of no other, and ending with the realisation of what beauty itself is.

211d

Diotima: ‘Here, above all, is our life worth living, my dear Socrates,’ said the stranger from Mantinea, ‘beholding beauty itself, a beauty which, once seen, will bear no comparison in your eyes with the gold or raiment or pretty boys and youths that so astound you now. Indeed, you and so many others, on seeing your favourites and being constantly in their company, would, if you possibly could, forgo even food and drink just to look at them and be with them.

211e

Diotima: ‘Well, then,’ said she, ‘what if someone were to attain the sight of beauty itself, simple, pure and unalloyed, uncluttered by human flesh, by colours and all the other trappings of mortality, but was able to see clearly the divine beauty itself, single in form? Would you think this is a mediocre life for a human being,’ she said, ‘looking to that place and contemplating that beauty with that which is suited to do so, and being with it? Or do you not recognise,’ said she, ‘that there alone, beholding beauty with that with which one sees it, he would be enabled to bring forth not images of excellence, but true excellence, since he is in touch with true beauty, not an image? And bringing forth and nourishing true excellence, he is allowed to become a friend to the gods, and if any human being may be immortal, it is he.’”

212b

Socrates: “Well, Phaedrus, and everyone else too, that is what Diotima said, and I am persuaded by her, and having been persuaded I endeavour to persuade others that in acquiring this possession they will not easily obtain a better collaborator with human nature than Love. And so I declare that every man must honour Love, and I myself honour whatever belongs to love, and practise that above all else and call upon others to do so, and as best I can I praise the power and courage of Love, now and always.

212c

Socrates: “So, Phaedrus, that is my speech. You may regard it as a hymn of praise to Love, if you wish, otherwise call it whatever it pleases you to call it.”

Once Socrates had said all this, there was general praise, and Aristophanes was trying to explain that Socrates’ speech had made mention of his own speech. Suddenly there was a loud banging at the outer door, as though revellers had arrived, and the voice of a flute-girl was heard. So Agathon said to the slaves:

Agathon: “Please investigate this, and invite them in if they are acquaintances and, if not, tell them that we are not drinking and are already drawing to a close.”

212d

Not much later, they heard Alcibiades’ voice in the hall — extremely drunk, shouting loudly — and asking where Agathon was, and demanding to be brought to Agathon. He was led to the gathering by the flute-girl who was supporting him, and by some of his followers, and he stood in the doorway, garlanded in a thick wreath of ivy and violets with a vast quantity of ribbons on his head, and said,

Alcibiades: “Greetings, gentlemen. Will you accept a drunk man, totally and extremely so, as your companion in drink? Or should we just leave once we have crowned Agathon, which was the reason why we came? You see,” he said, “I was not able to get here yesterday, but now I have come with ribbons on my head, so that I may crown the head of the wisest and fairest, if I so describe him, with ribbons from my own head. So, will you laugh at me because I am drunk? But even if you laugh, I know quite well that I am speaking the truth anyway. These are my terms, so just tell me, here and now, shall I come in or not? Shall we drink together, or not?”

213a

Everyone applauded, and bade him enter and take a couch, and Agathon called him over. In he came, led by his cohort, untying the ribbons as he went so as to crown Agathon. Because the ribbons were in front of his eyes, he did not get a clear view of Socrates, but sat down beside Agathon, between him and Socrates, for Socrates had moved over when he saw him coming. As he sat down, he embraced Agathon and crowned him with the ribbons.

213b

Agathon: Then Agathon said, “Slaves, please take off Alcibiades’ sandals so that the three of us may recline on the couch.”

Alcibiades: “Of course,” said Alcibiades, “but who is our third companion in drink?” And as he said this he was turning around to look, saw Socrates, jumped up and exclaimed, “By Heracles! What have we here? This fellow Socrates? What is more, you were lying here to ambush me, making a sudden appearance, as you usually do, wherever I least expected you to be. So, why are you here now? And, more to the point, why are you reclining there? You did not recline beside Aristophanes or someone else who is deliberately comical. Oh no, you contrived to be beside the handsomest person in the place.”

213c

Socrates: And Socrates said, “Agathon, see if you can defend me, as my love for this man has become a significant issue for me. Indeed, from the very moment I came to love him, no longer am I allowed even to glance at or speak to a beauty, not even one, or else this fellow gets jealous and envious, acts outrageously, abuses me verbally and can barely restrain his fists. Watch out, even now, in case he does something. Reconcile us, and should he attempt to use violence please defend me, as I am in utter dread of his mad devotion to his friends.”

213d

Alcibiades: “No,” said Alcibiades, “for you and me there is no reconciliation, and I will get my revenge on you for all this some other time. For now, Agathon,” he said, “give me back some of those ribbons so that I may crown this, this wondrous head of his. Then he will not rebuke me because I crowned you and did not crown him when he, for his part, is victorious over everybody with his words always, not just the day before yesterday like you.” And as he said this he took the ribbons, crowned Socrates, and lay back on the couch.

213e

Alcibiades: Once he had settled back he said, “Well, gentlemen, it seems that you are sober. That is not allowed. You should drink, since that is what we agreed. So, I am appointing myself the person in charge of drinking, until you have all drunk enough. So Agathon, let someone bring a large drinking-cup, if there is one. No, we do not need that, slave. Bring that wine-cooler instead,” he said, having noted that it held more than half a gallon. Once this had been filled, he first quaffed its contents himself and then directed that it be refilled for Socrates. As this was happening, he said, ^{214a} “With Socrates, gentlemen, my cleverness comes to nothing. Yes, however much anyone orders him to drink, that he drinks in full without even getting the slightest bit drunk.”

214a

The slave filled the cup and Socrates drank it, and Eryximachus said,

214b

Eryximachus: “Alcibiades, whatever are we doing? Are we simply going to drink like men with a thirst on them, without either speaking or singing over our drinking cup?”

Alcibiades: So Alcibiades said, “Greetings to you Eryximachus, the best son of the best and most sound-minded of fathers.”

Eryximachus: “And the same to you,” said Eryximachus, “but what are we to do?”

Alcibiades: “Whatever you say. Yes, we should be persuaded by you, ‘for one medical man is worth just as much as many others.’⁴⁷ So prescribe whatever you wish.”

214c

Eryximachus: “Then listen,” said Eryximachus. “Before you came in we decided that each of us in turn, from left to right, should deliver a speech on Love, the fairest we could, and sing his praises. Now, everyone else has spoken, and since you have not spoken, but have finished drinking, it is only right that you speak, and having done so, give Socrates any instruction you like, and he should do the same to the person on his right, and so on.”

Alcibiades: “Well, Eryximachus,” he said, “that is a nice formulation, yet it would not be fair to pit a drunken man’s speech against speeches from sober men. What is more, my friend, do you believe anything of what Socrates said earlier? Are you aware that the facts are the complete opposite of what he said? Indeed, if I praise anyone other than himself, god or human, when the fellow is present, he will not restrain his hands from me.”

214d

Socrates: “Can you not mind your words?” said Socrates.

Alcibiades: “By Poseidon,” said Alcibiades, “do not oppose me, for there is no one else at all whom I would praise when you are present.”

Eryximachus: “Then do so, if you want to,” said Eryximachus. “Praise Socrates.”

214e

Alcibiades: “What are you saying?” said Alcibiades. “Do you think I should do this, Eryximachus? Attack him and punish the

man in front of you all?”

Socrates: “You! What have you in mind?” said Socrates. “Will you praise me for amusement, or what are you going to do?”

Alcibiades: “I am going to speak the truth, if you will allow me to. Will you?”

Socrates: “Yes, of course, the truth I allow, and even command you to speak.”

215a

Alcibiades: “I shall not delay then,” said Alcibiades, “and yet, there is something you need to do. If I say anything that is not true, stop me in mid-sentence if you wish, and say that I am telling a lie, for, I shall not tell lies deliberately. And yet, if my recollection flits hither and thither as I speak, do not be surprised; for, in my condition it is no easy matter to detail your strangeness fluently, and in due order.

Alcibiades: “By means of images, gentlemen, that is how I shall attempt to praise Socrates. Now, although he himself will probably think that this is for amusement, the image will actually be for the sake of truth rather than amusement. Indeed, I declare that he is just like those statues of Silenus⁴⁸ the craftsmen make, the ones that are found in statue shops, holding pipes or a flute, which when opened into two halves are found to contain images of the gods within them. What is more, I declare that he resembles Marsyas, the Satyr.⁴⁹ Yes, even you, Socrates, would presumably not dispute the fact that you resemble these creatures in form. But now, hear how you also resemble them in other respects. You are insolent, are you not? Indeed, if you do not agree I shall provide witnesses. But are you not a flute player? Yes, a more amazing player than that fellow anyway. He enchanted people by means of his instruments, with the power from his mouth, and so does anyone today who plays his compositions on the flute, and I say that whatever

Olympus played belonged to Marsyas, who taught him. Anyway, his compositions alone render the hearers possessed, whether played by a good flute player or a mediocre flute-girl, and because they are divine, they show us who stands in need of the gods and their initiations.

215c

Alcibiades: “Now, you differ from Marsyas in one respect only. You can do the very same thing without instruments, by means of bare words. At any rate, whenever we hear someone else, even an extremely good speaker, speaking other words, it is of no real interest to anyone. Yet when someone hears you, or hears your words spoken by someone else, even by an utterly abysmal speaker, regardless of whether a woman, a man, or a youth hears them, we are astounded and possessed. I myself, gentlemen — except that I would seem completely drunk — would have told you, on oath, how I have been affected by the words of this man and am still affected even now. For whenever I hear him my heart leaps more than that of the frenzied Corybantes,⁵⁰ and tears flow because of this man’s words, and I see that a whole host of others are affected in the same way. Now, when I heard Pericles, or the other good speakers, I thought they spoke well, but I did not experience anything of this kind, nor was my soul troubled, nor was I angered at my condition of slavery. Yet this Marsyas here has often brought me to the point where life did not seem to be worth living, because of the state I was in. Yes, Socrates, and you will not deny that this is true. And even now I myself know full well that if I were prepared to give him a hearing I could not hold firm, but would experience the same effects. For he compels me to accept that although there is much that I lack, I neglect myself, and am busy with the affairs of the Athenian populace. So I block my ears forcibly as though I were hearing the Sirens.⁵¹ I depart and am gone, for fear that I might grow old seated alongside him.

216a

Alcibiades: “There is something you might think that I do not have within me, a feeling of shame towards any other person. Well, I experience this towards him and no one else. Only towards him do I feel shame. For I am fully aware that although I am unable to argue against him and to evade doing what he directs me to do, yet when I get away from him, reputation in the eyes of the populace gets the better of me. So, I take to my heels and run away, and whenever I see him, our mutual agreements reduce me to shame. Yes, on many occasions I would have been pleased to see him no longer among us, and yet if that were to happen, I know quite well that I would be in far greater distress. So I just do not know how to deal with the man.

216c

Alcibiades: “That is how the flute songs of this satyr have affected me and many others. Hear now from me how closely he resembles the figures I likened him to, and how wondrous is the power he possesses. For mark my words, not one man among you knows him, but since I have begun, I will show you. Note the fact that Socrates has a loving disposition toward the beautiful ones, constantly associates with them, and is smitten, and what is more, he is in ignorance about everything, and knows nothing. That is his outward appearance. Is this not what a Silenus is like? Very much so. So this is the external guise he dons, just like the carved Silenus. But on the inside, my comrades in drink, once he is opened, can you even imagine how full of sound-mindedness he is? Take it from me, it is of no interest to him if someone is handsome. No, he despises this more than anyone could ever imagine. Nor does it matter if someone is wealthy or possesses any other honour that the multitude counts as a blessing. He thinks that all these acquisitions are worth nothing and that we are nothing. Mark my words. He is ironical too and spends his entire life playing

games with people. But when he has become serious and open, I do not know if anyone has seen the delights that lie within. But I did see them once, and to me they seemed so divine and golden, so utterly beautiful and wondrous, that I simply had to do whatever Socrates told me to do.

217a

Alcibiades: “I thought that he was in earnest about my youthful charm, and I regarded it as a god-send and wondrous piece of good luck for me, that by gratifying Socrates I might be able to hear everything the man knew, for I had an amazingly high opinion of my youthful attractions. Now, once I had thought about all this, although I was not previously in the habit of being alone with him with no attendant present, I then began sending the attendant away and being alone with him. Yes, I must tell you the truth in its entirety, so you should pay attention and, Socrates, contradict me if I lie. Anyway, gentlemen, I was all alone with him, and I thought he would immediately converse with me in solitude, as a lover does to his beloved. I was glad. But nothing of this sort happened at all. No, he would converse with me as usual, and after we had spent the day together he would depart and be gone. After this I invited him to join me in the gymnasium and I did exercise with him hoping to make some progress there. Now, he exercised with me and we wrestled many times when there was no one around, and... how should I say this? I still made no progress!

217c

Alcibiades: “Since I was achieving nothing with this approach, it seemed to me that I should approach the man with force, and not relent, and since I had set about this in the first place, I should now find out what the problem was. So I invited him to dine with me, just like a lover contriving after his beloved. Even then he was slow to accept my invitation, but nevertheless he was persuaded after a while. The first time he came he wanted to leave as soon as dinner was over, and on that occasion, I let

him go, out of shame. Next time I had a plan. Once we had dined I kept the conversation going far into the night, and when he wanted to leave I made the excuse that it was too late, and I forced him to stay over. He lay down on the couch beside mine, the one he had reclined on at dinner, and no one else was sleeping in the house besides ourselves. Up to this point I could properly tell the story to anyone, but you wouldn't hear the next part from me were it not, firstly, for the fact that, as the saying goes, 'the truth comes from wine and from children', and also because it does not seem right to me, now that I am praising Socrates, to hush up a splendid deed of his. And yet, I too have experienced being bitten by the viper. Indeed, they say, I believe, that someone who experiences this is unable to describe what it is like. No one can do so except the people who have been bitten. They alone can understand and be forgiving if people are inclined to do or say anything at all on account of the agony. Now, I have been bitten by something more painful, bitten too in the most painful part of me, in my heart or soul or whatever it should be called. There I have been assailed and bitten by philosophical arguments, which take hold, more fiercely than a viper, of a young soul not devoid of talent, grab it and make it do and say just about anything. I see Phaedrus here, Agathon too, Eryximachus, Pausanias, Aristodemus and Aristophanes, not to mention Socrates himself and anyone else who is present. Yes, you have all shared in the madness and frenzy of philosophy, so you should all listen to me. Indeed, you will forgive me for doing what I did then and for saying what I am saying now. The slaves and anyone else who is profane and crude should affix some very large doors to their ears.

218c

Alcibiades: "Well then, gentlemen, once the lamp had been extinguished and the slaves were out of the room, I decided I should dispense with the verbal niceties and speak my mind to him freely. So I shook him and said, 'Socrates, are you asleep?'"

Socrates: 'Not at all,' he replied.

Alcibiades: 'Well, do you know what I have been thinking?'

Socrates: 'What is it?'

Alcibiades: 'I think that you alone are worthy to become my lover,' I said, 'and it appears to me that you are reluctant to raise the matter with me. My position is as follows. I believe it would be utterly senseless of me not to gratify you in this respect and in respect of any property you might ask of me or of my friends. Indeed, for me nothing takes precedence over my becoming as good as I possibly can, and in this I believe I have no ally more accomplished than you. If I failed to gratify a man like you, I would feel far more shame before the men of understanding than I would before the mindless rabble.'

218d

Alcibiades: "Having heard all this, loaded with irony and very much himself, he said, in his accustomed manner,

Socrates: 'Dear Alcibiades, you must in truth be no ordinary man if what you say about me happens to be true, and there is some power in me that can make you a better person. For in that case, you are seeing a boundless beauty in me which is vastly superior to your fine features. Now, if you have seen it and you are trying to associate with me and exchange one beauty for another, then you are planning to get the better of me to no small extent. Rather, you are trying to acquire the truth of beauties instead of an opinion, and you are really thinking to exchange gold for brass.⁵² But you should take a better look, bless you, in case I am nothing, and you do not notice this. I tell you, keen vision at the mental level begins when the vision of our eyes starts to go into decline, and you are still a long way from that.'

219a

Alcibiades: “Once I had heard this, I said: ‘I have said what I have to say and I have spoken my mind, so you yourself should now consider what you believe is best for you and for me.’

Socrates: ‘Yes, that is well expressed,’ he said. ‘Indeed, from now on we will deliberate and do whatever appears best for both of us in relation to these issues or any others.’

219b

Alcibiades: “Well then, after this exchange, and having fired my darts at him, I thought I had wounded my quarry. Anyway, I stood up, gave him no further opportunity to speak, wrapped my own garment around him for it was winter, lay down under his short cloak, threw both arms around this truly supernatural and wonderful person, and lay there all night. And you will not say that I am lying about any of this either, Socrates. And yet, after my having done all this, he was so superior, contemptuous and overbearing as to laugh at my youthful charm, and, gentlemen of the jury, I did hold that in very high regard. Yes, you will be judges of the arrogance of Socrates for, mark my words ye gods and goddesses, I got up after sleeping with Socrates and nothing more had taken place than if I had slept with my father or elder brother.

219d

Alcibiades: “What state of mind do you think I was in after this episode? Although I felt disrespected, I still admired his nature, his sound-mindedness and his courage, for I had encountered the sort of man I had not believed I would ever encounter: such intelligence, such restraint! And so, although I was unable to be angry with him and be deprived of his company, I was still at a loss as to how to lead him on. Indeed, I knew full well that he was much more invulnerable to wealth than Ajax was to weapons of iron,⁵³ completely so, and he had evaded the only means whereby I thought I could capture him. So I was at a loss, and I went about, a more abject slave to the man than anyone

else on earth.

219e

Alcibiades: “Well, this all happened to me at an earlier date, and afterwards we were together on the military campaign at Potidaea⁵⁴ and we shared the same mess there. Now, in the first place, in hard times he was superior not only to me but to everyone else. When we were forced to go without food because we had been cut off somehow, as happens on such campaigns, the endurance of the others was nothing in comparison with his. And yet, in times of plenty, he alone was able to enjoy them, and in particular when it came to drinking, despite his unwillingness, he could defeat everyone if he was ever compelled to do so, and what is most amazing of all, no man alive has ever yet seen Socrates drunk. Yes, and I think that will be verified quite soon. Now, when enduring the winter — indeed the cold season up there is awful — he worked wonders, especially when on one occasion there was a terrible frost, and everyone either refused to go out or, if they did go out, they were clothed to a wondrous extent, wore shoes and swathed their feet in felt and wool. Yet this man went out among them wearing the sort of cloak he used to wear before it got cold, traversed the ice more easily than everyone else because he wore no shoes, and all the soldiers looked askance at him because they thought he despised them. Be that as it may, it is also worth hearing ‘what this man of endurance dared to do’⁵⁵ on one occasion while we were there on campaign. He began reflecting upon something one morning, standing there considering it, and when he was unsuccessful he did not give up, but stood there and kept enquiring. By midday people had noticed, and they said to one another, in amazement, that Socrates had been standing still since dawn thinking about something. Finally, when evening came, some Ionians came out after supper, for it was summertime, brought their pallets with them so as to sleep in the cool air, and at the same time, keep

watch to see if he would stand there all night. There he stood until dawn came and the sun had risen. Then he uttered a prayer to the sun and went on his way.

220d

Alcibiades: “Would you like to hear about the battle? Well, it is only right to give him due credit in this area too. In fact, when the battle took place, the one for which the generals gave me the award for bravery, it was he of all men who saved my life. I was wounded and he could not bring himself to desert me. No, he helped rescue both myself and my armour. Now, Socrates, at the time I called upon the generals to give the award for bravery to you, and you cannot rebuke me for saying this, nor can you claim that I am lying. Anyway, when the generals wanted to give me the award in view of my status, you yourself were more eager than the generals that I should have it rather than you.

221a

Alcibiades: “Then again, gentlemen, Socrates was a sight worth seeing when the army was in retreat at the battle of Delium.⁵⁶ Yes, as it happened, I was there on horseback, while he was on foot, in armour. At that stage everyone had scattered and he was retreating along with Laches, the general. I came upon them, and as soon as I saw them I called upon them both to be courageous, and I said that I would not desert either of them. Here I had even a finer perspective on Socrates than I had at Potidaea, for I had less fear because I was on horseback. Firstly, I could see how superior he was to Laches in composure, and what is more he seemed to me — if I may use your phrase, Aristophanes — to be proceeding, even on the battlefield, just as he does in the city, ‘head held high and darting his eyes’,⁵⁷ calmly observing friends and enemies, making it obvious that whoever touched this man would meet with some tough resistance. That is why he and his companion made their retreat in safety. As a general rule, those who behave in this manner on

the battlefield are never touched; no, it is the soldiers who are fleeing headlong who are pursued by the enemy.

221c

Alcibiades: “Now, I could find many other points on which to praise Socrates, and many more wonders too, although if I reflect on his conduct in general, such behaviour could probably be attributed to other people too. Yet the fact that he is like no other man of past ages, or anyone alive today, that’s what merits our unbounded amazement. Asked who Achilles was like, you could compare him to Brasidas⁵⁸ and others, and you could liken Pericles to Nestor or Antenor,⁵⁹ and there are others too, and you could make other comparisons on the same basis. But whom is this person like? He is so strange, that try as you might, you would not find anyone who even approaches the man himself or his words, either nowadays or in times past. You’d have to compare him to the creatures I mentioned, to the Sileni and satyrs, rather than to any human being, both himself and his words too.

221d

Alcibiades: “Yes, and this is what I omitted saying at the outset, that even his words are very like the Sileni that can be opened. If anyone were willing to listen to Socrates’ words, they would appear highly comical at first, words and phrases that clothe his speech, like the skin of some wanton satyr. Yes, he speaks of pack-asses and smiths, cobblers and tanners, and he seems to be continually making the same points about the same issues, so that any inexperienced or ignorant person would laugh at what he says. But, if you were to behold them when they are opened, and get inside them, you would find, firstly, that these words alone have intelligence within them, and that they are utterly divine, containing within themselves a vast number of elevated images of excellence, so far-reaching that they extend to everything that should properly be considered by anyone who intends to be noble and good.

222a

Alcibiades: “These, gentlemen, are my praises of Socrates, and I have also added my criticisms by telling you the wrongs he has done me. Yes, and I am not the only one to whom he has done this; no, he deceives Charmides, the son of Glaucon, Euthydemus, the son of Diocles, and many others in his guise as a lover, while he himself becomes more a beloved than a lover. I am making these points particularly to you, Agathon, lest you be deceived by him. Mind that you learn from our experiences and don’t learn through suffering, like the fool in the proverb.”⁶⁰

222c

Once Alcibiades had said all this, there was laughter at the frankness of the man because he still seemed to be in love with Socrates. Then Socrates himself said:

Socrates: “It seems to me, Alcibiades, that you are sober, or else you would not have attempted to conceal the real reason why you are saying all this by wrapping it up so cleverly, slipping it in at the end as a mere verbal aside, as if you didn’t say everything for one reason alone: to set myself and Agathon at variance with one another, on the presumption that I should love you and no one else, and that Agathon should be loved by you and by no one else. But you did not get away with it. No, your Satyr-play or Silenus-play has been exposed. But, my dear Agathon, do not let him make any more headway, but instead, see to it that no one sets you and me at odds.”

222d

Agathon: So Agathon replied, “Yes, indeed, Socrates, you are probably speaking the truth, as evidenced by his reclining between you and me in order to keep us apart. But he will get no further. I will go over and recline beside you.”

Socrates: “Very well,” said Socrates. “Recline here, below me.”

Alcibiades: “By Zeus,” said Alcibiades, “there is no end to what I must suffer at this man’s hands. He thinks he has to get the better of me in every respect. But, blessed man, if you will not allow anyone else to recline between us, why not allow Agathon to do so?”

222e

Socrates: “Impossible,” said Socrates, “for once you have praised me, I must praise the person on my right. So, if Agathon reclines below you, will he not presumably praise me again before he has received praise from me, as he should? So let it be, my friend, and do not envy the young man because he receives praise from me, for I am indeed extremely eager to sing his praises.”

223a

Agathon: “Yes, yes!” exclaimed Agathon. “There is no way I can remain here, Alcibiades. No, it is much better that I change places so that I may be praised by Socrates.”

Alcibiades: “This is what always happens,” said Alcibiades. “When Socrates is around it is impossible for anyone else to share the company of the beautiful ones. Even now, see how resourceful he is at finding a convincing excuse, so that this handsome fellow may recline beside Socrates himself.”

223b

Now, Agathon was getting up in order to recline beside Socrates when a whole crowd of revellers suddenly arrived at the doors and finding that they had been left open by someone who had left, they came right into our party and reclined on the couches. There was total confusion, all order was lost, and everyone was forced to drink vast quantities of wine. Aristodemus told us that Eryximachus, Phaedrus and a few others got up and left, while he himself fell asleep, and slept for quite some time, for the nights were long at that time of year. Towards daybreak, he awoke to the crowing of the cocks, and saw that everyone else

was either asleep or departing. Agathon, Aristophanes and Socrates were the only ones still awake, drinking from a large cup that they passed from left to right as Socrates engaged them in discussion. Aristodemus said that he did not recall most of the discussion because he had missed the start of it, and he was beginning to doze off anyway. Yet he did say, by way of summary, that Socrates was compelling them to agree that the man who knows how to compose comedies also knows how to compose tragedies, and that the skilled tragedian is also a comic poet. Well, as they were being pressed on these points, they were not following particularly well and they were nodding off. Aristophanes was the first to fall asleep, and, as day was breaking, so too did Agathon. Then Socrates, having lulled them to sleep, got up and went out, and Aristodemus followed him as usual. When he got to the Lyceum⁶¹ he washed himself, spent the day just like any other, and having done so, he went home in the evening to rest.

NOTES

1. Agathon was a tragic poet from Athens. None of his works survives. He is a major character in Aristophanes' *Thesmophoriazusae*.
2. Alcibiades was a prominent and controversial Athenian statesman, orator and general. He was a close associate of Socrates, and two dialogues that bear his name have been attributed to Plato.
3. Glaucon was one of Plato's brothers. He appears as a major interlocutor in Plato's *Republic*.
4. Aristodemus was a follower of Socrates. He is also mentioned in Xenophon's *Memorabilia* and in a fragment from Aristophanes' comedy *Banqueters* (fr.242).
5. Apollodorus was a follower of Socrates. He is mentioned in Plato's *Apology* and *Phaedo* as having been present at Socrates' defence speech, and at his execution.
6. The name Agathon means 'good man'. The original proverb was "Good men go uninvited to an inferior man's feast." (Eupolis, Fragment 289, Kock).
7. *Iliad* xvii.587-588.
8. *Iliad* ii.408.
9. An adaptation of *Iliad* x.224.
10. Dionysus was the god of wine and fertility.
11. Pausanias was a lover of Agathon. He also appears briefly in Plato's *Protagoras* (315d-e).
12. Aristophanes was an Athenian poet and comic playwright. He satirised the figure of Socrates in his play *Clouds*.
13. Eryximachus was an Athenian physician. He and his father Acumenos are both also mentioned in Plato's *Phaedrus* (227a, 268a).
14. Phaedrus was an aristocratic Athenian from the deme of Myrrhinus. He is vividly depicted as the main interlocutor in Plato's *Phaedrus*.
15. Euripides was an Athenian tragedian. He wrote two plays about Melanippe, *Melanippe Wise* and *Melanippe Captive*, which survive only in fragmentary form. The fragment quoted here (Fragment 488) is from the former.
16. Hesiod, *Theogony* 116 ff.
17. Acusilaus was an early compiler of genealogies.

18. Parmenides, Fragment 132 (B13, Diels-Kranz).
19. *Iliad* x.482, xv.262; *Odyssey* ix.381.
20. According to legend, Alcestis sacrificed herself in order to save her husband, King Admetus, something not even his own parents were willing to do. A version of this story was retold in Euripides' play, *Alcestis*.
21. Orpheus was a legendary poet and musician who managed to gain entrance to the underworld to rescue his wife, Eurydice.
22. Aeschylus, *Myrmidons*, Fragment 228 ff; *Iliad* xi.786 ff.
23. Harmodius and Aristogeiton were two lovers who became known as the 'Tyrannicides' for having killed Hipparchus, the brother of the Athenian tyrant Hippias, for which they were executed. Although they did not directly bring down the tyranny, it fell three years later, paving the way for Athenian democracy.
24. *Iliad* ii.71.
25. Heraclitus of Ephesus, sometimes referred to as 'the obscure', was a philosopher known for such gnomic utterances. The one quoted here is found elsewhere in a slightly modified version (Fragment B51, Diels-Kranz).
26. In Greek mythology, Polyhymnia was the Muse of sacred poetry.
27. *Iliad* v.385 ff.; *Odyssey* xi.305 ff.
28. Hephaestus was the god of blacksmiths, metalworkers, carpenters, and other craftspeople. He performed all of the blacksmithing for the other gods on Olympus. *Odyssey* viii.266 ff.
29. Arcadia was home to the city of Mantinea, which opposed Sparta. As retribution, the city had its population divided; Xenophon, *Hellenica* 5.2.5-7. Some scholars regard this reference as an anachronism because this event did not take place until 385, long after the dramatic date of this dialogue.
30. *Odyssey* xvii.219.
31. Hesiod, *Theogony* 176 ff, 746 ff.
32. *Iliad* xix.92-93, Lamb. Atē is the personification of Delusion.
33. A common adage, which Aristotle (*Rhetoric* 1406a17-23) attributes to the sophist and rhetorician Alcidas.
34. Adapted from Sophocles' *Thyestes*, Fragment 235b, Dindorf.

35. *Odyssey* viii.266-366. Hephaistos, the husband of Aphrodite, devised a trap that caught Ares in bed with his wife.
36. Euripides, *Stheneboea*, Fragment 663, Nauck.
37. The author of these lines is unknown. It is possible that Agathon himself composed them; cf. *Odyssey* v.391.
38. *Odyssey* xi.635.
39. By referring to the 'head of Gorgias', Socrates is punning on the 'head of a Gorgon', which was reputed to be capable of turning a man to stone. Gorgias' style, which Agathon emulated in his speech, was supposed to be utterly enchanting.
40. See 177d.
41. Euripides, *Hippolytus* 612.
42. He is a philosopher.
43. The Greek word *poiēsis* is often translated as 'poetry', but it also has the wider sense of production or making in general, as well as the narrower sense of a specifically literary production. Here Diotima moves between these two senses.
44. Codrus was a legendary king of Athens who, in fulfilment of a prophecy, willingly submitted to death to save Athens from invaders.
45. Lycurgus was a legendary king of Sparta who is credited with establishing the Spartan constitution.
46. Solon (c.630-560) was a famous and respected Athenian legislator.
47. *Iliad* xi.514.
48. Silenus was the oldest, wisest and most drunken of the Satyrs (male spirits who were sometimes depicted with horse ears and tails, or with goat-like features and often with large erections) who accompanied Dionysus. Intoxication inspired him with special knowledge and powers of prophecy.
49. Marsyas was an expert at playing the pipes. According to legend, he challenged Apollo to a musical contest and lost. As a punishment for his hubris he was flayed alive.
50. The drum and pipe music of the Corybantes, worshippers of Cybele, induced a curative frenzy in those who were deranged.
51. Sirens lured sailors to their death with their enchanting song. *Odyssey* xii.37-54, 154-200.

52. *Iliad* vi.232-236, where Glaucus exchanges golden armour for brass.
53. Ajax was a Greek hero, the greatest after Achilles. His enormous shield rendered him virtually invulnerable to the weapons of his enemies.
54. Potidaea was a Thracian city and ally of Athens, which revolted at the prompting of Corinth. It was defeated after a lengthy Athenian siege.
55. *Odyssey* iv.242, 271.
56. Delium was a city on the coast of Boeotia where the Athenians did battle with and were defeated by the Boeotians. This battle at retreat is also mentioned in Plato's *Laches* 181b.
57. Aristophanes, *Clouds* 362.
58. Brasidas was an extremely effective Spartan commander during the Peloponnesian War. He was killed in Amphipolis, a battle at which the Spartans defeated the Athenians.
59. Nestor, a Greek, and Antenor, a Trojan, were both wise counsellors to their respective sides during the Trojan War. *Iliad* i.248 and iii.148-151.
60. *Iliad* xvii.32.
61. The Lyceum was a gymnasium, which was situated to the east of Athens, outside the city walls.

Theaetetus

ΘΕΑΙΤΗΤΟΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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persons in the dialogue:

EUCLIDES *founder of Megarian school*

TERPSION *of Megara, friend of Euclides*

MALE SLAVE *of Euclides, oral reader*

THEODORUS *of Cyrene, geometer*

THEAETETUS *of Sounion, mathematician, geometer*

SOCRATES *of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus*

scene: at the house of Euclides in Megara / in a gymnasium in Athens

142a

Euclides: Ah, Terpsion, have you arrived from the country just now, or was it some time ago?¹

Terpsion: Quite some time ago. Indeed, I was looking for you around the marketplace and was surprised that I could not find you.

Euclides: Actually, I wasn't in the city.

Terpsion: Where were you then?

Euclides: As I was going down to the harbour, I came across Theaetetus being carried back to Athens from the army camp at Corinth.²

Terpsion: Was he alive or dead?

Euclides: Alive, but just barely so. He is in a bad way on account of his wounds, but worse still, he has caught the disease that broke out in the army.

142b

Terpsion: Oh, the dysentery?

Euclides: Yes.

Terpsion: What a man he is! And you say he is in peril of his life?

Euclides: A noble and good man, Terpsion. In fact, I also heard some people just now, full of praise for his role in the battle.

Terpsion: That is nothing particularly unusual. Indeed, it would have been much more surprising if he hadn't played such a role. More to the point, why did the man not stay here in Megara?

142c

Euclides: He was in a hurry to get home. Indeed, I asked him myself and advised him to stay, but he did not want to. So, I saw him on his way, and as I was coming back I was reminded of Socrates, and how prophetically he spoke in general, and about Theaetetus in particular. Socrates met him as a young man, I believe, shortly before his own death, and from the company and the discussions he was very pleased with his character. He recounted their discussions to me when I arrived in Athens, and they are well worth hearing, and he said that Theaetetus really must become famous, if he actually lived long enough.

142d

Terpsion: Well, it seems he was right about that anyway. But what were these discussions? Can you recount them?

143a

Euclides: No, by Zeus, not from memory at any rate. But I made notes at the time as soon as I arrived home, and later on I recollected them at my leisure and wrote them out. And whenever I went to Athens, I would ask Socrates again about whatever I did not remember, and once I got back here I would make corrections, so that I have now written out almost the entire discussion.

Terpsion: Yes, I have heard you say that before, and in fact I had always intended to ask you to present it, but I have put it off until now. But why don't we go through it now? Having just come in from the country, I really need to rest.

143b

Euclides: Actually, rest is not an unpleasant prospect for me either, as I accompanied Theaetetus as far as Erineos. So let's go inside, and this servant can read to us while we rest.

Terpsion: Well said.

Euclides: Now, this is the book, Terpsion. See the way I wrote the account not as Socrates recounted it to me, but as a dialogue with the men he was talking to, and he said these were the geometers Theodorus and Theaetetus. I wished to avoid inserting phrases between the words that were spoken, such as 'and I declared' or 'said', whenever Socrates spoke, or again 'he concurred' or 'he disagreed', whenever the respondent spoke. For this reason I wrote it as direct discourse, omitting all such phrases.

143c

Terpsion: There is no problem with that, Euclides.

Euclides: Well then, take the book and read it, boy.

143d

Socrates: Theodorus, if I cared more about people in Cyrene,³ I would ask you about its affairs and its populace, and whether any of the young folk there are showing any interest in geometry or any other branch of wisdom. But, in fact, my love for them is less than for the Athenians, so I am more eager to know which of our young people are likely to turn out well. I watch out for such young men myself as best I can, and I also ask others, once I see that the young want to associate with them. Of course, they come to you in no small numbers, and rightly so, as you deserve it in general, and also because of your knowledge of geometry. So, if you have come across anyone worthy of report, I would be glad to hear about them.

143e

Theodorus: Well, Socrates, I have come across one such young man among your citizenry, and it is well worth hearing what I

have to say about him. Now, if he were handsome, I would be afraid to speak enthusiastically lest I might seem to have feelings for him. Now, and I hope I don't upset you when I say, he is not handsome and he is quite like you, with the snub nose and bulging eyes, though they are less pronounced in his case. So I am speaking without fear. You may rest assured that of all the youths I met previously – and there have been many – I have seen none with such wonderful natural endowments. I never imagined that a man who learns so keenly what others find difficult could still be extremely modest and also as manly as anyone else, and I do not see this happening elsewhere. But those who are sharp-witted and intelligent and have good memories, like this fellow, are often quick to anger and are borne hither and thither like ships without ballast, being more mad than manly, while the slower sort approach study with some reluctance and are full of forgetfulness. But this youth takes to learning and enquiry so smoothly, steadily and productively, with great modesty, like a stream of silently flowing oil, that you are amazed that one so young could achieve so much.

144b

Socrates: That is good news. But which of our citizens is his father?

Theodorus: I have heard his name, but do not remember it. But look, he is the one in the middle of the group coming towards us. The young man and these companions of his were oiling themselves a moment ago on the running track outside, and they seem to have finished that now, so they are coming in here. See if you recognise him.

144c

Socrates: I do recognise him. It is the son of Euphronios of Sounion,⁴ a man who was very like the boy you described and generally well regarded; and, indeed, he also left quite a

substantial inheritance. But I do not know the young man's name.

Theodorus: Socrates, his name is Theaetetus. However, I believe that the inheritance has been squandered by the trustees. But, nevertheless, he is wonderfully generous with his money, Socrates.

144d

Socrates: You are describing an excellent man. Ask him to come here and sit beside me.

Theodorus: I shall. Theaetetus, sit here beside Socrates.

Socrates: Yes, indeed, Theaetetus, so that I can scrutinise for myself the sort of face I have, for Theodorus says that I have a face like yours. However, if we both had lyres, and he said that they were tuned in like manner, would we just believe him or would we find out whether he was speaking as a musician?

144e

Theaetetus: We would find that out.

Socrates: We would believe him, would we not, if we discovered he was a musician, but we would be unconvinced if he were not?

Theaetetus: True.

Socrates: Now, I presume that if the similarity of our faces is of any concern to us, we would ask if the speaker was a portrait artist or not.

145a

Theaetetus: I think so.

Socrates: And does Theodorus know portraiture?

Theaetetus: Not as far as I know anyway.

Socrates: Nor geometry either?

Theaetetus: He certainly does know geometry, Socrates.

Socrates: What about astronomy, calculation, music and the various branches of education?

Theaetetus: Well, I think so.

Socrates: Well then, if he says that there is some physical resemblance between us, which he either praises or criticises, it is not worth paying much attention to him.

Theaetetus: Perhaps not.

Socrates: However, what if he were to praise either of our souls for wisdom or excellence? Wouldn't it be good for the recipient of the praise to exhibit his quality eagerly, while the other watches him closely?

145b

Theaetetus: Yes certainly, Socrates.

Socrates: Now, the time has come, dear Theaetetus, for you to give your demonstration whilst I watch closely, since, mark my words, Theodorus has praised many strangers and citizens to me, but never in the way that he praised you just now.

Theaetetus: That's all very well, Socrates, but take care that he was not speaking in jest.

145c

Socrates: No, that is not Theodorus' way. But do not be hesitant about our agreement by pretending that this man is jesting, in case we have to call him as a witness. No one will doubt his words, so just stand bravely by our agreement.

Theaetetus: Well, if it seems right to you, that is what I must do.

Socrates: Now, tell me this. I presume you are learning some geometry from Theodorus?

Theaetetus: I am indeed.

145d

Socrates: And astronomy, harmony and calculation?

Theaetetus: Well, I am trying to, anyway.

Socrates: Yes. And so am I, my boy, from Theodorus and others who, I believe, have some knowledge of these topics. And although I fare quite well with them in most respects, I am perplexed over a minor issue that I must consider with you, and our friends here. Now, tell me. Does learning not consist in becoming wiser about whatever one is learning?

Theaetetus: How could it be otherwise?

Socrates: And it is on account of wisdom, I imagine, that the wise are wise.

Theaetetus: Yes.

145e

Socrates: And does this differ in any way from knowledge?

Theaetetus: Does what differ?

Socrates: Wisdom! Aren't people wise in the matters in which they are knowledgeable?

Theaetetus: Of course.

Socrates: So are knowledge and wisdom the same?

Theaetetus: Yes.

146a

Socrates: Well now, this is what perplexes me, and I cannot grasp adequately for myself what knowledge actually is. So now can we speak of this? What do you say? Which of us will speak first? If he goes wrong he will sit down, and whoever goes wrong after him will also sit down and be 'donkey', as the children say in the ball game. But whoever comes through without error will be our king, and may order us to answer any question he likes. Why are you silent? Hopefully I am not being ill-mannered, Theodorus, due to my love of discourse, and

eagerness to make us engage in discourse, and become friendly and familiar with one another.

146b

Theodorus: Oh there is nothing ill-mannered about that, Socrates. But direct one of the young men to respond to you, since I am unaccustomed to such discussions as these, and I am too old to get used to them now. It would be suitable for these chaps, and they would make much more progress, since in truth the young make more progress in everything. So go on, just as you began. Don't give up on Theaetetus. Question him.

Socrates: Now, Theaetetus, you hear what Theodorus is saying, and I doubt if you would wish to disbelieve him, nor is it proper for a younger man to disobey the directions of a wise man in such matters. Come on, declare clearly and nobly what you think knowledge is.

146c

Theaetetus: Well, Socrates, I must, since you are both telling me to do so. In any event, if I make any error you will correct it.

Socrates: Yes, certainly, if we are able to.

Theaetetus: I think that whatever one learns from Theodorus is knowledge – geometry and those subjects you listed just now – and so also is cobbling and the other manufacturing skills. Each of these and all of these are knowledge, and not something else.

146d

Socrates: How noble and generous, my friend. You are asked for one thing and you provide many, favouring variety over simplicity.

Theaetetus: Why do you say that, Socrates?

Socrates: Well, perhaps it is nothing, but I shall tell you what I think anyway. Whenever you refer to cobbling, are you talking about anything other than the knowledge of making shoes?

Theaetetus: Nothing else.

Socrates: And what about carpentry? Do you mean anything other than the knowledge of making wooden objects?

146e

Theaetetus: No, that's it.

Socrates: In both cases, aren't you defining what each is knowledge of?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: But, Theaetetus, you were not asked what knowledge is of, or how many kinds there are. That was not the point. Indeed, we did not ask the question from a desire to count them, but we wanted to know what knowledge itself actually is. Or am I making no sense?

Theaetetus: No, you are absolutely correct.

Socrates: Well, consider this also. If someone were to ask us about one of the ordinary things around us – for example, what clay is – would we not be silly to answer potters' clay, ovenmakers' clay, brick-makers' clay?

147a

Theaetetus: Surely.

Socrates: Firstly, we would be silly to imagine that the questioner understands anything from our answers whenever we say 'clay', whether we add 'of modellers' or of any other craftsmen. Or do you think anyone understands any name of anything without knowing what that thing is?

147b

Theaetetus: Not at all.

Socrates: Then neither does anyone understand knowledge of shoe-making who does not know knowledge.

Theaetetus: He does not.

Socrates: So, whoever is ignorant of knowledge does not understand cobbling or any other skill.

Theaetetus: That's it.

Socrates: So, when we respond with the name of some skill when we are asked what knowledge is, that is a ridiculous answer. Indeed the answer says 'knowledge of something', and that does not answer the question.

147c

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Socrates: Well then, we seem to be going the long way around instead of answering plainly and briefly. Thus, on the question about clay, we could say, plainly and simply, that it is earth mixed with water, regardless of whose clay it is.

Theaetetus: Oh it seems easy when you put it like that, Socrates. However, it is very likely that what you are asking about is like what came up recently in conversation between myself and your namesake here, Socrates.⁵

147d

Socrates: Like what, Theaetetus?

Theaetetus: Theodorus here was illustrating something about powers to us, showing that a threefoot square and a five-foot square do not have a common measure with respect to a single foot. He dealt with each in this way until he reached seventeen, and then he stopped for some reason. Now, since the number of powers appeared unlimited, it occurred to us to try to comprehend them into a unity by which we could refer to all these powers.

147e

Socrates: And did you find something like this?

Theaetetus: I think that we did. But see if you agree.

Socrates: Tell me.

Theaetetus: We divided all number into two. Those that arise by multiplying equal numbers we likened to a square shape, and called them both square and equilateral numbers.

Socrates: Yes, that's good.

Theaetetus: However, between these numbers are all those, such as three and five, which cannot be generated by multiplying equal numbers. These are produced by multiplying greater by lesser, or lesser by greater, and the sides that enclose them are of different lengths, so we likened them to an oblong shape, and called them oblong numbers.

148a

Socrates: Excellent. But what did you do next?

Theaetetus: Whatever lines form an equilateral flat number⁶ when they are made into squares, we defined as magnitudes, while the lines whose squares form an oblong flat number, we defined as powers, as they do not have a measure, common in magnitude, with the other magnitudes, though the flat numbers they can form do have such a measure. Similar considerations apply to solid structures.

148b

Socrates: Well that is excellent, my boys, and I don't think that Theodorus will be open to a charge of perjury.

Theaetetus: Very well, Socrates, but I would not be able to answer what you are asking about knowledge in the very way I spoke about magnitudes and powers. However, I think that's the sort of wording you are looking for, so Theodorus may prove false after all.

148c

Socrates: Well, suppose he had praised you as a runner, saying that he had never come across a young man who could run like this, and you were then beaten in a race by the champion in his prime. Do you think that his praise would be any less true?

Theaetetus: I do not.

Socrates: And do you think that the search for knowledge, in the manner I have just described, is something trivial, or a task for those at the pinnacle in every respect?

Theaetetus: Oh, by Zeus, I really believe it is for those at the absolute pinnacle.

148d

Socrates: Well then, be confident about yourself. Believe that Theodorus is right, and exert yourself in every way, both in general and to arrive at an account of what knowledge actually is.

Theaetetus: If exertion is all we need, Socrates, it will come to light.

Socrates: Go on then. Indeed, you showed the approach very nicely just now, so try imitating your answer about powers. Just as you encompassed the many powers in a single form, so also describe the many types of knowledge in a single account.

148e

Theaetetus: Be assured, Socrates, that I have embarked upon this enquiry many times on hearing reports of the questions you ask. However, I am never able to persuade myself that I have anything useful to say, nor have I heard anyone else speaking in the way you are exhorting me. Then again, I can't give up the preoccupation either.

Socrates: For you are in labour, dear Theaetetus, because you have conceived and are not barren.

149a

Theaetetus: I don't know about that, Socrates. I am only describing what I experience.

Socrates: How comical! Have you not heard that I am the son of a fine, burly midwife named Phaenarete?⁷

Theaetetus: Yes, I heard that before.

Socrates: Now, have you also heard that I practise the same skill?

Theaetetus: Not at all.

Socrates: Well it is true, believe me! But you must not tell everyone else about me, my friend, as they are unaware that I have this skill. And since they do not know this about me, they never say it. But they do say that I am very strange, and that I make men perplexed. Surely you have also heard that?

149b

Theaetetus: I have, indeed.

Socrates: Well, shall I tell you the reason?

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Well, if you consider the status of all midwives overall, you will understand what I mean more easily. Indeed, I presume you know that no women, who are themselves still conceiving and bearing children, act as midwives to others, but only those who can no longer bear children.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Artemis is responsible for this, so they say, because she has been allotted responsibility for child-bearing, though she is childless.⁸ So she did not give the midwife's role to those who are barren, since human nature is too weak to understand a skill of which it has no experience. Instead, she assigned it to those who are past child-bearing age, in honour of their likeness to herself.

149c

Theaetetus: Quite likely.

Socrates: And isn't it both likely, and necessarily the case, that the midwives recognise, better than anyone, which women are

with child and which are not?

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed.

Socrates: And, indeed, the midwives are able to arouse the pangs or allay them as they so wish by administering potions or incantations. They can deliver difficult births, and if they believe the embryo should miscarry, they bring on miscarriage.

149d

Theaetetus: This is so.

Socrates: Well, have you noticed something else about them? That they are the most ingenious matchmakers since they are omniscient when it comes to knowing the types of men with whom various women should consort to produce the most excellent children?

Theaetetus: No, I didn't know that at all.

Socrates: Then rest assured that they value this skill more than the cutting of the umbilical cord. Yes, think about it. Do you believe that tending and harvesting the fruits of the earth is the same skill as knowing the types of plants that should be sown in various types of soil?

149e

Theaetetus: It is the same skill.

Socrates: And with a woman, my friend, do you think there is one skill dealing with types and another dealing with offspring?

Theaetetus: That is not very likely.

Socrates: No, it is not. However, because men and women are brought together in an improper and unskilled manner, which is called procuring, the midwives shun matchmaking, as they are respectable women who fear that through involvement in matchmaking they may be accused of procuring. Yet proper matchmaking is somehow a role only for the true midwives.

150a

Theaetetus: So it appears.

Socrates: Such is the role of the midwives, but it is a lesser role than mine. Indeed, it is not the custom of women to bring forth images on some occasions, and at other times true offspring, which are not easy to distinguish. If women did this, the greatest and noblest task of midwives would be to decide which was true and which was not. Do you not agree?

150b

Theaetetus: I do, indeed.

Socrates: Now, my skill of midwifery is, in general, similar in character to theirs, but it differs by delivering men and not women, and by looking after their souls rather than their bodies when in labour. But the greatest thing about my skill is that it is able to test, in every respect, whether the mind of the young man is bringing forth an image and a lie, or something genuine and true. Now, I do have this in common with the female midwives: I bring to birth no wisdom. And many people reproach me for this, since I ask questions of others while I myself proclaim nothing about anything, because I have no wisdom. Their reproach is true, but the reason is that the god compels me to act as a midwife and has prevented me from giving birth. So, of course, I myself am not at all wise, nor have I any invention that is born of my own soul. However, it is different for those who associate with me. Some of them also appear quite ignorant at first, but as our relationship proceeds, all whom the god allows, progress to a wonderful degree. Such is their own belief and that of others, and it is obvious that they have never learned anything from me. Rather, they have discovered from themselves much that is beautiful, and have brought it to birth. However, both I and the god are responsible for the delivery. The proof is that over the years, many who were ignorant of this regarded themselves as responsible,

despised me, and went away sooner than they should, persuaded either by themselves or by others. But once they had left me, they miscarried whatever remained within them through bad company, and destroyed through improper care whatever fruits I had delivered from them. Placing more value on images and lies than upon the truth, they ended up being regarded as ignorant both by themselves and by everyone else. One such person was Aristides, the son of Lysimachus,⁹ and there have been many others. If these men ever come back again, imploring my company with extraordinary imprecations, the familiar daimon¹⁰ forbids me from associating with some of them, while it allows me to associate with others, and these men make progress once more. Now, my associates have another experience in common with women in childbirth. They are pained and full of distress both night and day, even more than the women, but my skills can arouse or relieve this pain, and that is the plight they are in. But, Theaetetus, some who seem to me to have nothing within them to bring forth, I matchmake favourably with someone else, and with God's help I guess quite competently whose company will benefit them, knowing that they have no need for me. I have handed many over to Prodicus,¹¹ and many to other wise and inspired men. Now, excellent friend, the reason I am speaking to you at such length is that I suspect, as you yourself believe, that you are pained by something you are carrying within. So come to me, the son of a midwife, who is skilled in the midwife's art, and strive to answer my questions as best you can. And if I consider something you have been saying to be an image and untrue, and I take it out and discard it, do not be angry with me like new mothers over their children. Indeed, many before you, dear friend, had such an attitude towards me as to actually bite me whenever I take something nonsensical away from them. They do not believe that I do this with good intentions, and they are far from realising that no god ever intends harm towards humanity, nor

do I act in this way from ill intentions. But I am not allowed to accept falsehood or to conceal the truth. So start again, Theaetetus, and try to state what knowledge actually is. And do not say that you are not able, for if God wills it and you summon up your manhood, you will be able.

151d

Theaetetus: Well now, Socrates, with such encouragement from you, it would be a disgrace if a man did not strive to the utmost to say what he can. So then, it seems to me that whoever knows something perceives that which he knows. So, for now anyway, it appears that knowledge is nothing other than perception.

151e

Socrates: Spoken nobly and courageously, my boy. That is how you should speak when proclaiming your views. Come on, let us examine it together and whether it happens to be genuine or a wind-egg. Are you saying that knowledge is perception?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, it really seems that you have made no ordinary statement about knowledge, but one that Protagoras¹² also made, though he said the same things in a somewhat different way. He says, as you know, that man is the measure of all things: of those that are, that they are, and of those that are not, that they are not. Indeed, I presume you have read this?

152a

Theaetetus: Yes, I have read it many times.

Socrates: Does this not somehow mean that, in each case, as something appears to me, so it is for me, and again, as it appears to you, so it is for you – you and I being ‘man’.

Theaetetus: Yes, this is what it means.

Socrates: Now, a wise man is not likely to talk nonsense, so let us follow his argument. Is it true that sometimes when the same

wind is blowing, one of us may be cold while the other is not, or one of us a little cold while the other is very cold?

152b

Theaetetus: Of course.

Socrates: Now, at that time, can we say whether this wind, in itself, is cold or not? Or should we accept from Protagoras that it is cold for the person who feels cold, but not for the person who doesn't?

Theaetetus: It seems we should.

Socrates: And is that how it appears to each person?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: But does 'it appears' mean 'it is perceived'?

Theaetetus: It does.

Socrates: Then appearance and perception are the same in the case of warmth, and all such matters. Indeed, how things are perceived is how things are likely to be for each person.

152c

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Socrates: So, perception is always of what is, and it is not false since it is knowledge.

Theaetetus: So it appears.

Socrates: Well then, by the Graces, was Protagoras an utterly wise person who spoke this riddle to us common crowd while he divulged the truth¹³ to his disciples in secret?

Theaetetus: Whatever do you mean by that, Socrates?

152d

Socrates: I shall tell you, and this is surely no ordinary account. It states that nothing just by itself is one, nor may you correctly refer to it as some thing, nor as any kind of thing. But if you say

it is large, it will also appear to be small; and if you say it is heavy, it will also appear light; and so it is for everything, because nothing is one, or some thing, or of a particular kind. In fact, everything arises from movement and change and intermingling, and we actually say that these things are, but we are not referring to them correctly, for nothing ever is, but is always becoming. The entire tradition of the wise, except Parmenides, also agrees about this, including both Protagoras and Heraclitus, and Empedocles and the supreme poets from each branch of poetry – Epicharmus of the comic, and Homer of the tragic.¹⁴ And when Homer said, “Ocean is the source of the gods, and Tethys is their mother”,¹⁵ he meant that everything is born from flux and change. Or don’t you think this is what he meant?

152e

Theaetetus: I do, indeed.

153a

Socrates: Is there anyone who could do battle against such a vast army, with Homer as their general, and not become a laughing stock?

Theaetetus: That would not be easy, Socrates.

Socrates: It would not, Theaetetus, as there are also the following cogent indications that the account is correct, since movement produces becoming and what seems to be, while inactivity produces non-being and destruction. Indeed, heat and fire, which actually generate and regulate everything else, are themselves generated from movement and friction, and these are both activities. Aren’t these the origins of fire?

153b

Theaetetus: They certainly are.

Socrates: And, indeed, the race of living creatures is sprung from the same processes.

Theaetetus: It must be.

Socrates: And isn't the condition of our bodies corrupted by inactivity and idleness, but preserved for the most part by exercise and movement?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: And what of the condition of the soul? Isn't it through instruction and attention, which are activities, that it acquires learning and is preserved and becomes better, while through inactivity, which is both lack of attention and ignorance, it does not understand anything and forgets whatever it does understand?

153c

Theaetetus: It certainly does.

Socrates: So, activity is good for both body and soul, while inactivity is the opposite.

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Socrates: I can tell you more about such matters as absence of wind and calm seas, where the stillness decays and corrupts things, while different conditions will preserve them. But in addition to this, the ultimate evidence I bring forward is the golden cord that Homer declares to be the very sun itself, and he explains that as long as the heavens and the sun are in motion, all things are, and are preserved among both gods and men. However, should this cease and be tied down, everything would be destroyed, and as they say the world would be turned upside down.¹⁶

153d

Theaetetus: Yes, Socrates, it seems to me that that is exactly what he is explaining.

Socrates: Therefore, my friend, you must appreciate to begin with that in the case of the eyes, what you refer to as white

colour is not something separate outside of your eyes, nor is it in your eyes, nor should you assign any location to it, for it would then be abiding in that place and would not be in the process of becoming.

153e

Theaetetus: But how does it work?

Socrates: Let us pursue the current argument by proposing that nothing just by itself is one. And thus it will be evident that black or white or any other colour has arisen from the eyes hitting upon the relevant motion. Indeed, each so-called colour will be neither that which strikes nor that which is struck, but something that has arisen in between, private to each. Or would you maintain that each colour appears to you just as it does to a dog, or any other animal?

154a

Theaetetus: By Zeus, I would not!

Socrates: What about this? Does anything at all appear similar to you and to another person? Are you certain of this? Or are you even more certain that it does not appear the same even to yourself, because you are never in the same state as yourself?

Theaetetus: That's even truer than your first example.

Socrates: Now, if whatever we measured ourselves by, or touched, was large or white or hot, it would never become different through encountering something else, unless it itself actually changed. But on the other hand, if whatever is measuring or touching was large or white or hot, it would not have become different when another thing drew near or underwent some process, while nothing happened to itself. As things stand now, my friend, we are forced so easily into extraordinary and comical utterances, as Protagoras, and anyone who tries to make the same point as he does, would maintain.

154b

Theaetetus: What sort of utterances do you mean?

Socrates: Take a simple example, and you will know all that I have in mind. Presume there are six dice and you introduce four dice beside them. We say that they are more than the four, indeed one-and-a-half times the four. However, if you introduce twelve dice, the six will be fewer, in fact half of twelve, and that is the only acceptable description. Or would you accept any other?

154c

Theaetetus: I would not.

Socrates: Well then, what if Protagoras or someone else were to ask you, ‘Theaetetus, is there any way for something to become bigger or more numerous, other than by being increased?’ What would be your response?

Theaetetus: Socrates, if I were to give my immediate opinion on this question, I would answer that it is not possible. But based on your previous question, being wary of contradicting myself, I would say that it is possible.

154d

Socrates: By Hera, my friend, a good and divine response. However, it seems that if you do say that this is possible, the consequences of Euripides’ words will befall you, for your tongue will be beyond refutation, but your heart will not.¹⁷

Theaetetus: True.

Socrates: Now, if you and I were clever and wise, and had searched all the contents of our hearts, we would now spend the remaining time probing the abundant resources at our disposal, as we joined in some sort of sophistical contest, banging our arguments against one another. But now, seeing that we are common men, we shall first prefer to review, in their own terms, the exact thoughts that we ourselves are thinking, and

whether they seem to us to be concordant with one another or entirely discordant.

154e

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly, I would prefer that.

Socrates: And so would I. Now since that is so, shall we examine ourselves faithfully and patiently, considering once more what these appearances within us actually are? On considering the first of them, I believe we shall say that nothing would ever become greater or lesser, either in bulk or numerically, as long as it is equal to itself. Isn't this the case?

155a

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: And the second of them will have us say that if nothing is either added to or removed from something, it will neither increase nor diminish, but it will remain equal.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

155b

Socrates: And won't the third have us say that nothing can be what it was not before, without becoming and a process of becoming?

Theaetetus: It certainly seems so.

Socrates: Now, I believe that these admissions are battling with one another in our soul, whenever we discuss the matter of the dice, or whenever we say that I, who at my age am neither getting bigger nor going in the opposite direction, am now taller than a youth like you, but later on that I am shorter, over the course of one year. This happens without my frame being reduced, but through yours becoming bigger. But note that I am, at a later time, what I was not before, though I have not undergone a process of becoming. But without such a process it is impossible to become smaller, and without losing any of my bulk I would not have become shorter. And there are, of course,

thousands upon thousands of such instances once we accept all this. I presume you are following, Theaetetus. You actually seem to have some familiarity with such issues.

155c

Theaetetus: I am, Socrates, and by the gods, I wonder intensely what they actually mean. And the truth is I sometimes get dizzy from looking at them.

155d

Socrates: Well, my friend, Theodorus here seems to have made no poor estimate of your endowments. Indeed, this wonder is the particular characteristic of a philosopher, since philosophy has no other origin than this, and it seems that whoever said that Iris was born from Thaumas was not a bad genealogist.¹⁸ But do you now understand why these things are so, based on the statement we are attributing to Protagoras? Or is it not yet clear?

Theaetetus: It is not clear to me yet.

Socrates: Now, will you feel grateful to me if I assist you in a thorough examination of the truth hidden in the thought of a famous man? Nay, of famous men?

155e

Theaetetus: How could I feel anything other than huge gratitude?

Socrates: Then look about, and take care lest any of the uninitiated is listening in. These are the fellows who believe that there is nothing except what they can hold fast with both hands and do not accept that activities and processes, and all that is unseen, have a share in being.

156a

Theaetetus: Yes of course, Socrates. You are describing some quite tough and obstinate characters.

Socrates: Yes, my boy, they are indeed most ill-educated. But there are others, much more refined, whose mysteries I am about to reveal to you. Now, their first principle, on which hangs all we have been discussing just now, is that all is motion and there is nothing else besides this. The motion has two forms, and each is unlimited in multiplicity, though one has an active power while the other is passive. From the mutual intercourse and friction of these two with one another, numerous offspring arise that are limitless in number but always twins. One twin is the perceptible, and the other is the perception that constantly accompanies the perceptible and is born along with it. For the perceptions, then, we have such names as seeings and hearings, smellings, cold and hot, and of course pleasures and pains, desires and fears, as they are called, and others. Indeed, those without names are innumerable, and those that have been given names are very numerous. On the other hand, the category of perceptibles has, in turn, a common origin with each of the perceptions, so with variegated seeings there are variegated colours, and the same applies to hearings and sounds, and for the other perceptions the other kindred perceptibles arise. Now, Theaetetus, what does this story tell us about the previous subjects? Can you see?

156c

Theaetetus: Not very well, Socrates.

Socrates: Well, let us see if we can bring it to a conclusion. It does indeed mean, just as we are saying, that all things are in motion, though some are quick in their movements and others are slow. Now, anything slow has its motion in the same place and relative to whatever comes near, and it produces offspring in this way. But whatever is produced is quicker, and moves from place to place, and its motion naturally involves a place to place movement. Therefore, whenever an eye and something that can be evaluated by it draw near and generate whiteness

and its associated perception – neither of which would ever have arisen if either of them had encountered something different – there is movement between them at that time. This movement is sight on the part of the eyes, and whiteness on the part of whatever joins in the production of the colour. So the eye becomes full of sight, and then it sees and becomes not sight but a seeing eye, while its partner in the production of colour is saturated in whiteness and becomes, for its part, not whiteness but something white, be it wood or stone or anything else that happens to be coloured with a colour of this sort. And this is actually how things work in general. Hard and hot and all else should be understood in the same way, to be nothing just by itself, as we were saying before, but in their mutual intercourse everything of every kind arises from the movement, since there is actually no firm basis for thinking that the active or passive is something in isolation. For there is not an active until it is joined to a passive, nor a passive until it is joined to an active. And that which joins one thing and is active turns out to be passive when it encounters something else. And the consequence of all this, just as we were saying at the beginning, is that nothing just by itself is one, but is constantly coming into being with something, and ‘to be’ should be entirely removed from use, not that we have not been compelled to use it just now, through habit and ignorance. But the account of these wise men says we must not do this, nor should we accept the word ‘something’ or ‘of something’ or ‘mine’ or ‘this’ or ‘that’ or any other name that would make it fixed. Instead we should declare, in accord with nature, that they are coming into being, being produced and being destroyed or changed, since if anyone fixes anything with a word, whoever does this will be easily refuted. This is also how we should refer to particulars and to aggregates of many, aggregates that are designated as ‘man’ or ‘stone’, and each living creature and form. Now, Theaetetus, don’t you think this is delightful, and so delicious that you could

eat it?

157c

Theaetetus: Well, I don't know, Socrates. Indeed, I cannot understand you, and whether you believe what you are saying or testing me.

Socrates: My friend, you are forgetting that I know nothing of such matters, nor do I regard them as my own offspring, since I am barren. However, I am acting as midwife to you, and on this account I am charming you, and offering pieces of wisdom for you to taste until I draw out that belief of yours into the light. Once it is out, I shall evaluate whether it shows itself to be a wind-egg or a genuine birth. So take heart, and persist! Answer truly and courageously, and tell us how things appear to you, no matter what I ask you about.

157d

Theaetetus: Very well, ask me.

Socrates: Then tell me if you agree that nothing is good or beautiful, or anything else we just mentioned, but is constantly becoming so.

Theaetetus: Well, I think so, since it appears marvellously reasonable when I hear you describing it like this, and it should be accepted exactly as you have recounted it.

157e

Socrates: In that case, let us not leave out anything that is missing from it. What is missing is consideration of dreaming, diseases in general, and also madness, and the extent to which we are said to err in hearing and seeing and in our other perceptions. Indeed, you know that in all these cases the account we gave just now seems to be proved wrong by common consent, as false perceptions certainly arise in us under such circumstances, and so for each person the appearances are far removed from what is. Rather, on the

contrary, nothing at all that appears to be, is.

158a

Theaetetus: What you say is perfectly true, Socrates.

Socrates: Well then, what argument is left for the one who proposes that perception is knowledge, and that for the person to whom they appear, whatever appears to be, is, in each case?

Theaetetus: Well, Socrates, I hesitate to say that I don't know what to say, since you rebuked me for saying that just now. Yet the truth is that I could never dispute that madmen and dreamers have false opinions, when one group believes they are gods, or the others, in their sleep, think that they have wings and are flying.

158b

Socrates: Are you not aware of a similar dispute about these, and about sleeping and waking in particular?

Theaetetus: What sort of dispute?

Socrates: It is a question that I believe you have heard asked many times. What proof could you provide if someone were to ask, right now, whether we are asleep at present and are dreaming everything that we are thinking, or awake and talking to one another in the waking state?

158c

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed, Socrates, I am at a loss as to what sort of proof should be provided since they both correspond so closely, just like mirrored dance movements. Indeed, there's no reason why our present conversation couldn't be a discussion with one another imagined in sleep. And, of course, whenever we are asleep, and imagine we are recounting dreams, the resemblance of one to the other is uncanny.

Socrates: You see then that there is plenty of room for dispute, when it is even disputed whether we are awake or asleep! And, indeed, as we spend a similar amount of time asleep and awake,

in either state our soul contends that the opinions held at that time are completely true. Consequently, we spend an equal time asserting that this realm is real, and we are equally confident in each case.

158d

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

Socrates: Doesn't the same argument apply to madness and disease, except that the durations are not equal?

Theaetetus: Correct.

Socrates: Well then, is truth to be determined by longer or shorter duration of time?

158e

Theaetetus: That would be entirely ridiculous.

Socrates: Well, have you any other obvious way of demonstrating which of these sets of opinions are true?

Theaetetus: I don't think so.

Socrates: Then you can hear from me how people talk about these matters when they designate the appearances of the moment as true for the person to whom they appear. I believe they would ask a question such as, "Theaetetus, would something that is completely different have the same capacity as that from which it is different? And let us not assume that we are asking about something that is the same in one respect but different in another. No, this is completely different."

159a

Theaetetus: In that case, it cannot have anything that is the same, either in capacity or anything else whatsoever, once it is altogether different.

Socrates: Now, must we not concede that such a thing is also unlike?

Theaetetus: Well, I think so.

Socrates: And if it happens to become like or unlike something, either itself or another, shall we say that in becoming like, it is becoming the same, while in becoming unlike, it is becoming different?

Theaetetus: It must be so.

Socrates: And didn't we say before that there are many – indeed, unlimited – active elements, and that the same applies to passive elements?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: And also that anything that is paired with one thing and then with another will not produce the same things but different things.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

159b

Socrates: Now, let us discuss me and you and things in general, based upon the same argument. Take Socrates when healthy and Socrates when ill. Shall we say they are like one another or unlike one another?

Theaetetus: Are you referring to the unhealthy Socrates as a whole compared to the healthy Socrates as a whole?

Socrates: You have understood perfectly. I mean just that.

Theaetetus: Then of course they are unlike.

Socrates: And is he different then to the extent that he is unlike?

Theaetetus: He must be.

Socrates: And will you say the same about Socrates asleep, and in all the other conditions we mentioned just now?

159c

Theaetetus: I think so.

Socrates: Now, will each of the things whose nature is to act upon something else treat me in one way when it encounters healthy Socrates, and in a different way when it encounters unhealthy Socrates?

Theaetetus: Inevitably.

Socrates: Then is it the case that I who am passive, and this active, will produce different outcomes in each case?

Theaetetus: Indeed.

Socrates: So when I drink wine when healthy, would it appear pleasant and sweet to me?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: Indeed, based upon what we agreed before, the active and the passive, both moving simultaneously, produce both sweetness and perception. Since perception is associated with the passive, it turns the tongue into something that perceives, while the sweetness associated with the wine moves about it and makes the wine both appear sweet and be sweet to the healthy tongue.

159d

Theaetetus: Yes. What we said before certainly concurs with this.

Socrates: But when it encounters the unhealthy Socrates, is that in truth someone different, and not the same person? Indeed, it approaches something that is unlike the first.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, a Socrates such as this, along with the draught of wine, gives rise to different outcomes, a perception of bitterness in the region of the tongue, while in the region of the wine, bitterness arises and moves, and so the wine becomes not

bitterness but bitter, while I become not perception but a perceiver.

159e

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed.

Socrates: So, I shall never come to perceive any other thing in this way, for there is another perception of the other thing, and this makes the perceiver different, and different in kind. Nor would that which is active towards me ever produce the same thing, or itself be the same sort of thing, in its encounter with something different. For having produced another from another, it will become different in kind.

160a

Theaetetus: This is so.

Socrates: Nor indeed shall I become such a perceiver by myself, nor will the active element become different by itself.

Theaetetus: No, it will not.

Socrates: No. But whenever I come to be perceiving, I must be perceiving something, for it is impossible to come to be perceiving and yet be perceiving nothing. And whenever sweet or bitter or such like arise, they must arise for some person, for it is impossible to become sweet, but sweet to no one.

160b

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

Socrates: What remains for us then, I believe, is that if we are, we are for one another, and if we become, we become for one another, since in fact necessity conjoins our being, yet it binds us to none of the others, or even to ourselves. So it leaves us bound to one another. Consequently, if someone says that something is, or becomes, he should say that 'it is or becomes for someone' or 'of something' or 'in relation to something'. But he should never say, nor allow someone else to say, that it is or becomes just by itself. That is what the argument we have been

expounding indicates.

160c

Theaetetus: Entirely so, Socrates.

Socrates: Now, since whatever is active towards me, is for me and for no one else, mustn't I also perceive it and no one else?

Theaetetus: It must be so.

Socrates: So, my perception is true for me, for it always belongs to what I am, and as Protagoras says, I am judge of the things that are for me, that they are, and also of the things that are not, that they are not.¹⁹

Theaetetus: So it seems.

160d

Socrates: Now, if I am not being deceived or erring in my thinking about things that are, or things that become, how could I fail to have knowledge of the things that I perceive?

Theaetetus: There is no way this could happen.

Socrates: Knowledge is nothing other than perception. That was an excellent saying of yours! So the various accounts turn out to be the same. Homer and Heraclitus and all their tribe say everything changes like a flowing stream; Protagoras, the wise, says man is the measure of all things; and now Theaetetus says that since these things are so, knowledge turns out to be perception. Is this so, Theaetetus? Shall we declare that this is like your newborn baby, which I have brought to birth? What do you say?

160e

Theaetetus: It must be so, Socrates.

Socrates: So, it seems that this is what we have at last produced with some difficulty, whatever it turns out to be. After the birth comes its infant ceremony, and we should faithfully carry it around the hearth²⁰ in the circle of discussion, on the lookout

lest the offspring be unworthy of rearing, since it is false and a wind-egg. Or do you believe that your offspring should be reared in any case, and not be set aside? Could you endure seeing it tested in argument, and not get violently angry if someone were to take away this, your first-born?

161a

Theodorus: Socrates, Theaetetus will endure, for he is not at all bad-tempered. But by the gods, do tell us exactly why this is not the case.

Socrates: You are a veritable lover of discourse, Theodorus, and it is kind of you to believe that I am some bag of arguments and will easily pull one out to explain that all this is not the case after all. But you do not understand what is going on, that none of these arguments ever comes forth from me, but from the one who is conversing with me, and I know nothing more than the little matter of how to take some argument from someone wise and receive it appropriately. This is what I shall now try to test from this young man, while I myself proclaim nothing.

161b

Theodorus: You are putting that very well, Socrates. Go ahead and do as you say.

Socrates: Now, Theodorus, do you know what amazes me about your friend, Protagoras?

Theodorus: What is it?

Socrates: Well, in general I am very pleased with his statement that for each person, what seems, also is. However, I wonder why he did not say at the beginning of ‘Truth’ that pig is the measure of all things, or baboon, or some other more unusual creature that has perception, is the measure. He could then have begun to speak to us grandly and contemptuously, demonstrating that while we admired him for his wisdom, like a god, he was actually no more intelligent than a tadpole, let

alone another human being. How else can we express this, Theodorus? For if the opinions formed through perception are indeed true for each person, and no one judges a person's experience better than himself, nor is anyone superior in deciding if the opinion of another is right or wrong, but as we have said many times, each person is himself the sole judge of his own affairs, and all these opinions are right and true, what, my friend, is the status of wise Protagoras? Does he properly deserve to be the teacher of others, for huge fees, and should we, in our relative ignorance, have recourse to Protagoras when each of us is himself the measure of his own wisdom? Should we conclude that Protagoras is saying all this in a popularist vein? I am staying quiet about myself and my art of midwifery for fear of the ridicule we shall incur, as will the conduct of dialectic in its entirety. For it is a vast and vain pursuit, is it not, to undertake the scrutiny and refutation of each other's notions and opinions, if the 'Truth' of Protagoras is true and each of us is right, and this truth is not a jest uttered from the inner sanctuary of the book.

162a

Theodorus: Socrates, as you said just now, Protagoras was my friend, so I could not bear to cooperate in his refutation. Nor, however, could I oppose you, contrary to my own opinion. So involve Theaetetus once more. He seemed to be responding very appropriately just now.

Socrates: Well, Theodorus, if you were to go to Sparta, would you have the right to watch other men, some quite paltry, exercising naked in the wrestling schools and not undress yourself and expose your own form alongside theirs?

162b

Theodorus: But why ever not, if they were prepared to trust me and be persuaded by me? Just as I think that I shall persuade you now to let me watch and not drag me into the gymnasium,

stiff with age, when you can wrestle with a younger, healthier man.

Socrates: Well, Theodorus, whatever pleases you does not displease me, as the proverb says, and so we should go back again to wise Theaetetus. First, Theaetetus, tell us about what we were saying just now, and whether you are surprised at suddenly proving to be just as wise as anyone else, whether man or god. Or would you say that the Protagorean measure applies any less to gods than to humans?

162c

Theaetetus: By Zeus, I would not. And to answer your question – yes, I am very surprised. Indeed when we recounted how men argue, when they assert that whatever seems, also is, for the person who thinks so, this sounded very good to me, but now the very opposite suddenly turns out to be the case.

162d

Socrates: Well, you are young, dear boy, so you listen intently to common talk and you believe it. Indeed, Protagoras or any of his spokesmen will reply to these arguments and say, “Noble youths and elders, you sit together indulging in common talk and you bring in the gods, whose existence or non-existence I exclude from my discourses and from my writings.²¹ And you say things that the multitude would accept when they hear them, like how terrible it would be if every person differed not in wisdom from the cattle in the fields. But proof and necessity never enter your pronouncements, and you rely on likelihood.” Yet, if Theodorus, or some other geometer, decided to use this method in geometry, he would not be worth one jot. So, in such important matters as these, both you and Theodorus must consider whether you will accept arguments based on persuasiveness and likelihood.

163a

Theaetetus: No, it's not right, Socrates. You would not say so, and neither would we.

Socrates: Then it seems we should think in a different way, based on the word of yourself and Theodorus.

Theaetetus: A different way. Yes, certainly.

Socrates: So, let us consider, in this different way, whether knowledge and perception are the same or different. Indeed, our entire discussion has somehow been dealing with this question, and for the sake of this we set in train this plethora of strange topics. Is this not true?

163b

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

Socrates: Shall we agree then that whatever we perceive by seeing or hearing is also known at the same time? In the case of foreigners, before we learn their language, shall we either maintain that we do not hear them when they speak or that we hear them and know what they mean? Or again, if we look at writing with no knowledge of it, shall we assert that we do not see it or that we know it if we actually see it?

Theaetetus: Socrates, we shall say that we know this about them anyway, what we see and hear. Their form and their colour are both seen and known, while high and low pitch are heard and also known at the same time. But whatever the scribe or the linguist teaches about these, we neither perceive by seeing nor by hearing, nor do we know it.

163c

Socrates: Excellent, Theaetetus, and it is best not to argue that point with you in order that your development may continue. But look, there is another issue looming. Figure out how to keep this one at bay.

Theaetetus: What sort of issue?

163d

Socrates: Something like this. If someone were to ask, “Suppose someone comes to know something at a certain time and still retains and preserves memory of that very thing, is it possible for him not to know it when he is remembering that very thing?” It seems I am being very long-winded, when I just want to ask if someone who has learned something could be remembering it, but not know it.

Theaetetus: How could he, Socrates? What you are describing would be bizarre.

Socrates: Am I talking nonsense then? But consider this. Don’t you say seeing is perceiving, and sight is perception?

Theaetetus: I do.

163e

Socrates: And someone who has seen something has acquired knowledge of that which he has seen, according to what we said just now.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: What about this? Do you agree that there is such a thing as memory?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: And is it memory of nothing or of something?

Theaetetus: Of something surely.

Socrates: Of things one has learned or perceived. Isn’t it memory of things of this sort?

Theaetetus: What else could it be?

Socrates: Does a person, on occasion, remember what he has seen?

Theaetetus: He remembers.

Socrates: And does he forget it when his eyes are closed?

Theaetetus: What an odd thing to say, Socrates!

Socrates: Yet we must say so if we are to salvage our previous argument, otherwise it is eliminated.

164a

Theaetetus: Yes, by Zeus, that's what I suspect too. But I don't quite understand why, so you tell me.

Socrates: Well, we say that whoever is seeing comes to have knowledge of that which he is seeing, for we have agreed that sight, perception and knowledge are the same.

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed.

Socrates: And yet the person who sees, and has come to have knowledge of what he has seen, does not see it when his eyes are closed though he does remember it. Is this so?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: But 'does not see' is the same as 'does not know', if in fact 'to see' is 'to know'.

164b

Theaetetus: True.

Socrates: So, it turns out that someone who has come to know something, and still remembers it, does not know it since he does not see it. And we said it would be bizarre if this were the case.

Theaetetus: What you say is very true.

Socrates: Then an impossible conclusion appears to follow if someone says that knowledge and perception are the same.

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Socrates: So, we have to say that they are different.

Theaetetus: Very likely.

Socrates: Well in that case, whatever is knowledge? It seems we must discuss this again from the beginning. But, Theaetetus, what on earth are we trying to do?

164c

Theaetetus: What are you referring to?

Socrates: We seem to me like uncouth fighting cocks that turn away and start to crow before we have won a victory over this argument.

Theaetetus: How do you mean?

Socrates: We seem to be satisfied that we have defeated the proposition by coming to an understanding, quite argumentatively, about the similarities between words. We claim to be philosophers, not debaters, yet we behave unconsciously just like these clever fellows.

164d

Theaetetus: I still do not understand what you are saying.

Socrates: Well, I shall try to clarify my own thoughts on the matter in any case. Now, we were asking if someone who has learned something and is remembering it could fail to know it, and we took the example of a person who has seen something and closed his eyes and is remembering it. We demonstrated that he does not know, and at the same time is remembering, and we said that that is impossible. And so, the Protagorean story met its downfall, and yours too – your statement that knowledge and perception are the same.

Theaetetus: So it appears.

164e

Socrates: My friend, I believe this would never have happened if the father of that other proposal were alive, since he would have defended it in all sorts of ways. But now we are mistreating

his orphan, and even the trustees left by Protagoras have no desire to help it, Theodorus here being one of them. Well then, for the sake of justice, we ourselves must come to its aid.

165a

Theodorus: Yes, Socrates, since I was not Protagoras' trustee. That was Callias, the son of Hipponicus.²² I somehow turned quickly away from pure discourse and inclined towards geometry, though I would be grateful to you if you came to his aid.

Socrates: Well spoken, Theodorus. Now consider the aid I shall proffer. For we could agree to even stranger things than before if, in our usual fashion, we do not pay attention to what we are saying in our affirmations and denials. Shall I explain this to you or to Theaetetus?

165b

Theodorus: No, explain it to the company. But let the younger man respond to you since he will be less shamed if he goes wrong.

Socrates: Let me then put the most formidable question, that goes something like this: Is it possible for the same person to know something and not know the thing that he knows?

Theodorus: Well, what answer shall we give, Theaetetus?

Theaetetus: Presumably it is impossible, in my opinion anyway.

Socrates: Not if you propose that seeing is the same as knowing. For how will you respond to the inescapable question that, as they say, traps you in a well shaft, when some audacious fellow puts his hand over one of your eyes and asks if you can see his cloak with that covered eye?

165c

Theaetetus: I think I would say that I cannot see it with that eye, but I can see it with the other one.

Socrates: So, do you both see and not see the same thing at the same time?

Theaetetus: Yes, in the way we have described it anyway.

Socrates: “That is not the question I put to you,” he will say. “I was asking if you do not know the thing that you know, regardless of how this occurs. What is not seen now turns out to be seen, yet you happen to have agreed that seeing is knowing, and not seeing is not knowing. Now work out the conclusion from all this.”

165d

Theaetetus: I am coming to conclusions contrary to what I was proposing before.

Socrates: Yes, my friend, and perhaps you would have had more experiences like this, if someone had gone on to ask you if it is possible to know accurately and dimly, or to know from close up but not from afar, or know the same thing thoroughly and vaguely. There are lots of other questions that a combative professional debater, lying in wait, would ask you, once you propose that knowledge and perception are the same. He would go on to attack hearing and smelling and all such perceptions, and would keep refuting you relentlessly until you were in awe of his enviable wisdom and totally entangled by him. And once he had overpowered you and tied you up, you would be released for a ransom amount that you both agreed upon. Perhaps you may ask what argument Protagoras will now proffer in defence of his own proposition. Shall we try to state it?

165e

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

166a

Socrates: Well, no doubt he will say all the things we say in his defence, and I believe he will also engage in dispute, despising us and saying:

“This Socrates, the simpleton! He tries to argue that I am the one who is ridiculous, because some little boy is frightened when Socrates asks him if the same person can remember something and not know it at the same time, and the boy, out of fear, says no because he cannot foresee the consequences. But the position is as follows, O idle Socrates! Whenever you investigate any of my propositions through questioning, then I am refuted only if the person questioned is defeated while answering exactly as I would answer. But if he answers in another way, it is the actual person questioned who is refuted.

“In this instance, do you think anyone will agree that someone’s present memory of things that he experienced is anything like the experience he was having at the time, and is no longer experiencing? Far from it. Or again, would anyone be reluctant to agree that the same person can both know and not know the same thing? Or even, if he was afraid of that proposition, would he ever concede that someone who is becoming unlike is the same as he was before becoming unlike? Indeed, if he must be on the lookout for the verbal traps that we each lay, will he ever agree there is a single person, and not a number of persons, and that these become unlimited, as long as the process of becoming unlike actually continues.

“Dear fellow,” he will say, “come to terms generously with what I actually propose, and prove if you can that private perceptions are not arising for each of us, or that if the perceptions that arise are private, what appears is not something that especially arises only for that person, or ‘is’ for that person, if we must use the word ‘is’.

“Now when you refer to pigs and baboons, you not only act like a pig yourself, but you persuade your hearers to treat my writings as you do, which is most improper.

“Indeed, I assert that what I have written is the truth, that each of us is indeed the measure of things that are and are not. However, there are countless differences between one person and another in this respect, because to one person certain things are and appear, while to another other things are and appear. I am far from denying that there is wisdom or a wise man, but the particular man whom I call wise is one who brings about change, and will make things appear and be good to us, when they both appear, and are, bad. And again, do not go chasing after this argument based on how I have expressed it, but note this clarification of what I mean. Recall how this was expressed in the earlier conversation, that to a sick man whatever he eats appears sour and is sour, while the opposite appears to be the case, and is the case, for a healthy man. Now, we should not portray one as wiser than the other, nor could we. Neither should we allege that the infirm man is ignorant because he holds such opinions, nor that the healthy man is wise because his views are different. No, one condition should be changed to the other because the other is better. And in education too, we should effect just such a change from one particular condition to a better one. And while the doctor effects the change with medicine, the sophist does it with his words. Indeed, no one ever made a man hold true opinions who previously held false opinions, for it is not possible either to think of things that are not, or of anything outside of what is experienced, and these are always true. I believe rather that in a degenerate condition of the soul he holds opinions appropriate to that condition, while in a sound

condition of the soul he is made to hold opinions of a different sort – a set of appearances that some naively refer to as true. However, I say that one set is better than the other, but not any truer.

“My dear Socrates, I am far from referring to the wise as tadpoles, but when it comes to the body I call them doctors, and when it comes to plants I call them farmers. Indeed, I say that these farmers engender sound, healthy and true perceptions in the plants whenever they are sick, in place of the degenerate perceptions, while the good and wise orators make whatever is beneficial rather than degenerate seem right to cities. Now, whatever seems right to each city is good and right for that city, as long as it is believed. But the wise man makes whatever is beneficial rather than degenerate seem right and be right for them, in each case. And on the same basis, the sophist is wise, and worth his large fees, as he too can educate pupils in this manner. And this is how some people are wiser than others while no one holds a false opinion, and you must put up with being a measure, whether you like it or not, as the salvation of this argument lies in these assertions.

“Now, if you intend to contradict it all over again, conduct your disputation by presenting a complete argument. Or if you prefer to use questions, then use questions, for we should not avoid that method either. Indeed an intelligent person should follow that approach rather than any other.

“However, heed the precept that your questioning be not unjust, as it is very unreasonable that a man who says that he cares about excellence should constantly pursue an unfair line of argument. Now, it is unfair in this context for someone to carry on this business without distinguishing between

disputation and dialogue. In disputation he may play and trip up his opponent as often as he can, but in dialectic he should be serious and also set his partner back on his feet, pointing out to him only those pitfalls into which he has been misled by himself or his former acquaintances. Once you act in this way, whoever spends time with you will blame themselves for their confusion and perplexity, and not you. And they will follow you and love you, and will hate themselves and flee from themselves into philosophy, so that they may become different people and be freed from what they were before. But if you do the opposite, as do most people, the consequences will be opposite, and instead of philosophers you will produce followers who hate the subject once they become older.

“Now if you listen to me, as I said before, you will settle down, without impatience and aggression but with a gracious mind, and really consider what precisely we mean when we proclaim that everything is motion, and that for each person, or city, whatever seems, also is. And based on this, you will reflect on whether knowledge and perception are the same or different, but not as you did just now, on the basis of familiar expressions and terminology that many people employ, in whatever manner occurs to them, causing endless confusion to one another.” Theodorus, this is the best I can do from my slender resources to offer assistance to your friend, but if the man himself were alive he would have defended his offspring more expansively.

168c

Theodorus: You are joking, Socrates. You have defended the man most vigorously.

168d

Socrates: It is nice of you to say so, my friend. But tell me, did you note what Protagoras was saying just now when he

reproached us for directing our arguments against a little child and using childish fear in refuting his views? He accused us of mere cleverness, extolled ‘the measure of all things’, and urged us to be serious about his argument.

Theodorus: How could I fail to notice that point, Socrates?

Socrates: In that case, do you think we should heed his injunction?

Theodorus: I certainly do.

Socrates: You see then that all the people here, except you, are small children. So if we are going to obey the man, you and I must be serious about this argument, as we ask and answer one another. Then at least we shall not be accused of boyish sport as we reconsider the argument.

168e

Theodorus: What? Surely Theaetetus could follow the scrutiny of an argument better than many a man with a long beard?

Socrates: Not better than you however, Theodorus. So do not presume that I should make every effort to defend your deceased companion while you do nothing. Come now, my friend, follow me for a while, at least until we establish whether it turns out that you are the measure when it comes to diagrams, or whether everyone is just like you, and sufficient unto themselves in astronomy and those other subjects in which you are indeed said to excel.

169a

Theodorus: Socrates, it is not easy for someone to avoid entering into an argument when they are sitting beside you, and I spoke nonsense just now, saying that you would not force me to undress and wrestle as the Spartans do, but would leave the decision up to me. No, you are inclined to the trickery of Sciron!²³ Indeed, the Spartans ask you to undress or go away, but you behave more like Antaeus, for once someone draws

near you won't let him go until you have undressed him and forced him into a verbal wrestling match.²⁴

169b

Socrates: Theodorus, you have presented an excellent image for the malady that afflicts me. However, I am even more stubborn than the characters you mention. Many a Heracles and Theseus have crossed my path, powerful speakers who have taken me apart, but I shall never back down at all, such is the awful passion for these exercises that has gripped me. So do not refuse to enter the ring with me, as you will benefit yourself as well as me.

169c

Theodorus: I have no argument against this, so lead me wherever you wish. I must fully accept the destiny you decree in these matters, and submit to being cross-examined. However, I shall not be able to surrender myself to you beyond what you are proposing.

Socrates: Well, that is far enough. Now, there is one thing you must help me to guard against. We should not slip into a childish form of discussion and be reproached again for this.

169d

Theodorus: Well, I shall do the best I can.

Socrates: In that case, let us take this up again at the same point as before, and see if we were right or wrong to find fault in and criticise this proposition because it made each person self-sufficient in intelligence, and made Protagoras concede to us that, in matters of better and worse, some excel over others, and these are, in fact, wise. Isn't this where we were?

Theodorus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, if Protagoras himself were actually present and had agreed, and we had not made this concession on his behalf in order to help him, there would be no need to seek certainty

by resuming the discussion. But now, perhaps, someone will suggest that we lack authority to agree on his behalf, and that it would be better to agree this particular point fully with greater clarity, because whether or not this is the case is no small matter.

169e

Theodorus: What you say is true.

Socrates: Then let us get this agreement as concisely as possible from his own argument rather than anything else.

170a

Theodorus: How?

Socrates: As follows. He says, I believe, that whatever seems also is, for the person to whom it seems.

Theodorus: Yes, he does say that.

Socrates: So then, Protagoras, we too are describing the opinions of a man, in fact of all men, and we declare that there is no one who does not believe himself wiser than others in some respects, while others are wiser in other respects. Indeed, in the greatest dangers, whether in battle or disease or storms at sea, they will regard those in authority as gods, who are expected to act as saviours, though their superiority lies in knowledge and in nothing else. And the entire human race is full of people in search of teachers and leaders for themselves, for other creatures, and for their activities, while others think themselves capable of teaching and leading. Now, in all these cases, what else can we say except that the people themselves believe that there is wisdom and ignorance among them?

170b

Theodorus: Nothing else.

Socrates: Don't they believe that wisdom is true thought, while ignorance is false opinion?

170c

Theodorus: Of course.

Socrates: So what will become of the proposition, Protagoras? Should we say that people always think what is true, or do they sometimes think what is true and at other times what is false? Indeed, it seems to follow from either option that people do not always think what is true. Rather, they think both. Consider this, Theodorus. Would you yourself, or any follower of Protagoras, be prepared to contend that no one ever believes that someone else is ignorant and thinks falsely?

Theodorus: No one would accept that, Socrates.

170d

Socrates: And yet this is where the proposition inevitably leads, the proposition which states that man is the measure of all things.

Theodorus: How so?

Socrates: Whenever you have formed a judgement by yourself, and you present an opinion to me about something, we should say that this opinion is true for you, based upon Protagoras' proposition. But don't the rest of us become judges of your judgement? Or do we decide that you always form true opinions? Or do thousands who hold different views oppose you every time, in the belief that your thought and judgement is false?

170e

Theodorus: They do indeed, by Zeus, Socrates – thousands, and more, as Homer says,²⁵ who inflict all the troubles of mankind upon me.

Socrates: What then? Do you like us to say that in this case, you are forming opinions that are true for you, but false for thousands?

Theodorus: It seems that this must follow from the proposition.

Socrates: And what about Protagoras himself? Mustn't it follow that if he himself did not believe that man was the measure, nor did the world in general – which, in fact, it does not – this truth that the man has written down would be true for no one? However, if he believed it himself but the majority did not agree, note firstly that insofar as more people disagree than agree, to that extent it is more not so than so.

171a

Theodorus: It must, if it is to be so, and not so, based upon individual opinion.

Socrates: Secondly – and this is the cleverest aspect – since Protagoras agrees that everyone thinks things that are, presumably he accepts as true the thinking of those who hold a view contrary to his own thinking, and they think that Protagoras is speaking falsely.

Theodorus: Yes, certainly.

171b

Socrates: Wouldn't he be accepting that his own thinking is false, if he agrees that the thinking of those who believe him to be speaking falsely, is true?

Theodorus: He must.

Socrates: And yet the opponents do not accept that they themselves are speaking falsely.

Theodorus: No, they do not.

Socrates: While Protagoras again agrees that this opinion is true on the basis of what he has written.

Theodorus: So it appears.

171c

Socrates: Then it will be disputed by everyone, beginning with Protagoras, who adds his own agreement whenever he concedes that someone who says the very opposite is forming a true

opinion. In that case, Protagoras himself will be accepting that neither a dog, nor any random person, is the measure of anything which he has not learned. Isn't this so?

Theodorus: It is so.

Socrates: Well, since it is disputed by everyone, the 'Truth of Protagoras' would be true for no one, neither for the man himself nor for anyone else.

Theodorus: We are running my old friend too hard, Socrates!

Socrates: But it is not actually clear whether we are running along the right course. Now, it is quite likely that the man is wiser than we, since he is older. And if he suddenly popped his head up from below, as far as the neck, he would expose me as talking a lot of nonsense – yes, that is likely; you too for agreeing with me – and then he would dive back down, disappear and be gone. However, I think that we must accept ourselves just as we are, and always state how things seem to us. Accordingly, shouldn't we declare that any person at all will probably agree that some men are wiser than others, and some are more ignorant than others?

171d

Theodorus: Well, I think so anyway.

Socrates: Yes. The best way to establish the argument is by means of the addition we made as we defended Protagoras. We said that in most cases, such as hot, dry, sweet, and any matters of that sort, as it seems to each, so it also is for each. However, if the argument is somehow to concede that one person excels over another in some matters, it will prefer to state that when it comes to health and disease, it is not every woman, child or beast who is competent to cure itself and realise what is healthy for itself, but in these cases, if any, one person does excel over another.

171e

Theodorus: That is how it seems to me, anyway.

Socrates: However, in civic affairs, concerning what is noble and disgraceful, just and unjust, sacred and profane, whatever each city believes and designates as lawful for itself is, in truth, lawful for that city. And in these matters, no citizen is wiser than another citizen, nor is any city wiser than another city. But when it comes to deciding what is advantageous or disadvantageous for itself, in these cases, if at all, the argument will accept that one adviser is superior to another, and the opinion of one city is in truth better than that of another, and would never dare to propose that whatever a city believes to be to its own advantage, and designates as such, will certainly turn out that way. But in the cases I referred to before, just and unjust, sacred and profane, people wish to insist that there is not one of them which by nature has an existence of its own. Instead, they say that whatever seems so to the people becomes true at the time that it seems so, and for as long as it seems so. And even people who do not entirely hold to Protagoras' argument somehow regard this formulation as wisdom. Argument after argument is descending upon us, Theodorus, and larger is emerging from smaller.

172c

Theodorus: But haven't we plenty of free time, Socrates?

Socrates: It appears that we do, yes. And I have often reflected, my blessed friend, at one time or another, and indeed just now, that those who spend a lot of time in philosophic pursuits naturally prove to be amusing speakers if they end up in courts of law.

Theodorus: What do you mean by that?

Socrates: Those who have been hanging around law courts and such places from their younger years will surely seem like slaves rather than free-born men when compared to those

brought up in philosophy and kindred pursuits.

172d

Theodorus: But in what way?

Socrates: In the sense that the philosophers have the free time, which you mentioned, and they hold their discussions peacefully and in their own time, just as we are doing now, taking up argument after argument. Indeed, we are already on our third. They can do exactly the same as us if a new topic interests them more than the current one, and they will not care at all whether the discussion be long or short, if only they may encounter what is.

But the other sort always speak under pressure of time, from the water that flows from the clock,²⁶ and they are not allowed to make speeches on matters close to their hearts. Their opponent stands over them, armed with compulsion and a written document that deals with every issue, from which they cannot depart. Their words are always about a fellow slave, addressed to a master who sits with some charge in his hands, and their disputes are not of a general nature, but the issue is always personal, and his life is often at stake. And in consequence of all this they become intense and shrewd, knowing how to flatter their master in words and beguile him in deed, but their souls become small and warped.

Slavishness from youth upwards has removed their growth, uprightness and freedom, and forced them into crooked ways, casting huge perils and trepidations on their still tender souls, which they are unable to bear with justice and truth. They turn directly to falsehood and mutual injustice, and are utterly bowed down and confined. The result is that they turn out as men who from childhood upwards are devoid

of health of mind, though they believe that they have become clever and wise. So that is the sort of men they are, Theodorus. But what do you want to say about men of our sort? Do you want us to describe them, or leave the matter and return again to the argument in case we very much abuse this freedom in switching between topics that we referred to just now?

173c

Theodorus: Certainly not, Socrates. I want us to describe them! Indeed, you expressed this very well. We who move in such circles are not servants to these arguments, but our arguments are just like our servants, and each of them must wait to be concluded whenever we see fit. Nor, in fact, is there any jury or audience evaluating or dominating us, as if we were playwrights.

Socrates: Well, since that is your view, it seems we should talk about the best of them, for what could anyone say about the mediocre exemplars of philosophy anyway? But the best of them, from their early years, do not even know the way to the Agora, nor the whereabouts of the law courts or the Council Chamber or any other public meeting place in the city. They neither hear the edicts being proclaimed nor look at the laws when they are written. They would not even dream of involvement with political parties struggling for power, alliances, banquets or revelling with flute-girls. Whether someone in the city is high-born or low-born, or there is some problem with their ancestry, male or female, concerns him no more than the number of pints in the ocean, as they say. Indeed, he does not even know that he does not know about these matters, for he does not avoid them for the sake of reputation, but in truth it is only his body that is situated in the city as a visitor, while his mind regards all this as small and insignificant, despises it and takes flight, as Pindar says, “above the heavens

and beneath the earth”, measuring the earth’s vast surfaces, studying the stars, and searching out in every way the complete nature of each whole among the things that are, never lowering itself to anything that is near at hand.

174a

Theodorus: What do you mean by this, Socrates?

Socrates: One example, Theodorus, is the case of Thales,²⁷ who fell into a well as he was gazing up at the stars, and some clever and witty Thracian maidservant mocked him, saying that he was so eager to know what was in the sky that he forgot about what was right there under his feet. Now, the same gibe will apply to everyone whose life is spent in philosophy. Indeed, such a person will actually be unaware of his next-door neighbour, not only of what the man does, but even whether he is human at all, or some other creature. What precisely man is, and what action or response is appropriate to human nature and distinguishes man from other creatures? This is his search, and these are the questions he is at pains to answer. I presume you understand now, Theodorus. Do you?

174b

Theodorus: I do indeed, and what you are saying is true.

174c

Socrates: Therefore, my friend, such a person will provide amusement not only to Thracian girls but to the world in general, when he meets someone privately or in public, as I said in the beginning, and is compelled to discuss matters under his feet or before his eyes, in a courtroom or anywhere else. Through inexperience he falls into wells, and all manner of perplexity, and his clumsiness is terrible, giving rise to a reputation for silliness. Of course when it comes to slander, he has nothing special to say against anyone since he does not know anything bad about anyone, having never been interested in such matters, and being at a loss he becomes a

figure of fun. When he hears the praises and the proud boasts of others, he is conspicuous for his unfeigned, genuine laughter that makes him seem ridiculous. And, indeed, when a tyrant or king is being praised, he believes he is hearing one of the stock-keepers, such as a swineherd or shepherd or some dairyman, being congratulated on a high milk yield, and he thinks that the rulers tend and exploit a more difficult and treacherous creature than the stock-keepers, and that his own busyness renders a king as uncouth and ill-educated within his city walls as any shepherd in a mountain enclosure.

Whenever the philosopher hears that someone has acquired an astonishing amount of land, as he has acquired thousands of acres or even more, he thinks it but a trifle, as he is accustomed to viewing the earth in its entirety. And when they sing the praises of families, as though someone is a nobleman if they have seven wealthy grandfathers to their credit, he thinks that the speaker is utterly dim, and partial in his view, as his lack of education renders him unable to see the universal, or to figure out that each person has had countless thousands of grandfathers and ancestors. Among them, in every case, there were often rich and poor, kings and slaves, non-Greeks and Greeks, in their thousands. So boasting about a list of twenty-five ancestors stretching back to Heracles, the son of Amphitryon, appears remarkably small-minded to him, and he laughs because they cannot banish petty vanity from their unthinking soul by working out that the twenty-fifth descendant of Amphitryon was such a man as fate decreed he should be, and the fiftieth will be so too.

Now, in all these cases the philosopher will be derided by the world, partly because he seems to be above it all, and partly

due to his ignorance and perplexity in the particulars of daily life.

175b

Theodorus: You are describing the situation very comprehensively, Socrates.

Socrates: However, my friend, the philosopher may sometimes draw someone upwards, and the person may wish, through him, to go beyond “What injustice have I done to you, or you to me?”, in favour of examining justice and injustice themselves, what each is in itself, and what distinguishes them from all else and from one another. Or he may go beyond “Is the king happy?”, “Is a wealthy man happy?”, and enquire into kingship and human happiness and misery in general, and what sort of states they both are, and the manner in which it is appropriate for a human being to acquire the one and avoid the other. Now, when that shrewd and litigious little soul must in turn give an account of all these matters, then the situation is again reversed. He is dizzy and suspended from on high. Looking down from the sky above, he is both troubled and perplexed by the strange experience. And his stammering provides no amusement to the girls from Thrace or any uneducated folk, since they are unaware of his plight. No, he amuses all who have been brought up, not in the manner of slaves, but the exact opposite.

There they are, Theodorus, the dispositions of the two types of men. One has been truly brought up in freedom and leisure, and you obviously call him a philosopher, to whom it is no disgrace to seem simple-minded and of no account when he encounters the menial tasks of a slave, and does not know how to tidy up bedclothes or make flavoursome food or a flattering speech. The other type can render all such services

efficiently and promptly, but knows not how to dress like a free man or take the harmony of discourse, and sing the praises of the life of the gods or of blessed men.

176a

Theodorus: Socrates, if you were to persuade everyone with your words, as you have persuaded me, there would be more peace and less trouble among men.

Socrates: But evils cannot be eradicated, Theodorus, for there must always be something in opposition to the good. Neither can they be situated among the gods, but they must haunt the mortal nature and prowl about the earth. So we should endeavour to flee from here to there as quickly as we can, and to flee is to be as like unto God as we can, and to be like God is to become just and holy with the help of wisdom. However, my friend, it is not very easy to convince people that the reasons we should be pursuing excellence and avoiding vice are not the reasons the world gives – namely, that we should practise the one and avoid the other so that we are reputed to be good men and not bad. This actually sounds to me like the idle talk of old women, as they say. So, we should speak the truth, which is that God is not unjust in any way whatsoever, but is as just as it is possible to be, and there is no one more like unto God than the person among us who has, in turn, become as just as possible. And therein lies the true measure of a man's accomplishment, and indeed his worthlessness and inhumanity, for knowledge of this is wisdom and true excellence, while ignorance of this is folly and manifest vice. Any other seeming accomplishment or wisdom is vulgar in the case of political sovereignty, and commonplace when it comes to the other arts. Therefore, it is best by far not to concede to an evildoer, or one whose words or deeds are unholy, that his roguery is an accomplishment, for they delight in that reproach and fancy they are hearing not that they are ridiculous burdens to the earth, but men well

fitted for survival in the city. So the truth must be spoken, that they are the sort of people they believe they are not, and all the more so because they do not believe so. Indeed, they are ignorant of the penalty for injustice, which is the last thing they should be ignorant of. For the penalty is not what they think it is, scourging or execution, which offenders sometimes avoid suffering. No, this is a penalty that cannot be avoided.

176e

Theodorus: What penalty do you mean?

Socrates: There are two patterns established in what is – one of divine blessedness, the other of godless wretchedness – but they do not see that this is how things are. So, through their foolishness and utter mindlessness, they fail to realise that because of unjust actions they are becoming like one pattern and unlike the other. So their lives are like the pattern they resemble, and that is the penalty they pay. But if we should tell them that unless they set aside their accomplishment, the place that is pure of evils will not receive them when they die – but they will continue in their own pattern of living, evil men among their own kind – they will listen to us as though we were mindless folk addressing clever rogues.

177a

Theodorus: They certainly will, Socrates!

177b

Socrates: Yes, my friend, I know. However, there is one thing that happens to them in private whenever they must present an argument, and accept one in return, about the matters they disparage, and are prepared to persist manfully for an extended duration without running away like cowards. Strangely, my dear friend, they end up dissatisfied with what they themselves are saying, and their eloquence somehow dries up, so that they seem no different from children. Now, let us call a halt, since this is really a digression. Otherwise, the continued influx of

issues will overwhelm our initial discussion. So if you agree, let's return to the previous topic.

177c

Theodorus: A digression like this makes quite pleasant listening for me, Socrates, since it is easier to follow at my age. However, let us go back to the other discussion again if you think fit.

Socrates: Well, I believe we were at a point in the discussion at which we said that the people who declare that being is in motion – and that whatever seems is for the person to whom it seems – are in general prepared to assert this confidently. And especially in the case of justice, they state most emphatically that whatever a city regards as just, and decrees to be just, is just for that city for as long as the decree remains in force. However, when it comes to what's good, there is no one so heroic that he would also dare to contend that whatever a city believes to be beneficial for itself, and decrees to be so, is actually beneficial for as long as the decree stands, unless he is referring to the mere name. But that would be making a joke of our discussion, wouldn't it?

177d

Theodorus: It surely would.

177e

Socrates: Yes, he should not refer to the mere name, but should consider the thing that is being named.

Theodorus: Of course.

Socrates: But whatever name it is given, a city surely legislates and enacts all the laws with the aim of maximising the benefit to itself, according to its understanding and ability. Or does it look to some other factor when it legislates?

Theodorus: Not at all.

178a

Socrates: Now, does each city always succeed, or do they also frequently miss the mark?

Theodorus: Well, I think they also miss the mark.

Socrates: Then again, anyone at all might accept these same points more readily if someone were to ask about the entire kind to which benefit also belongs, and that, I believe, involves future time. For whenever we legislate, we enact laws that will be beneficial in time to come, and this we would properly designate as ‘future’.

Theodorus: Yes, certainly.

178b

Socrates: Come on. Let us question Protagoras in this way, or anyone who says the same thing he says. “You say, Protagoras, that man is the measure of everything, including white, heavy, light, and everything like that, without exception. For having the criterion of these within himself as he experiences them, so he thinks they are, and what he thinks is true for him, and is so for him. Isn’t this so?”

Theodorus: Just so.

Socrates: “And what about future events, Protagoras? Shall we say that he has the criterion of these within himself, and that as he thinks they will be, so they also turn out for the person who thinks so? In the case of heat, suppose a layman thinks he is about to get a fever and will have a temperature, while his doctor thinks the opposite. Which opinion should we say that the future will confirm? Or will it confirm both, and for the doctor neither temperature nor fever will arise in the man, while for the man himself there will be both?”

178c

Theodorus: That would be ridiculous.

Socrates: “Yes, and I think that the farmer’s opinion about wine, rather than the lute-player’s, is superior regarding the sweetness or bitterness of the future product.”

178d

Theodorus: Of course.

Socrates: “Nor again would the trainer judge better than the musician about what will be discordant or melodious, and what will seem to be melodious even to the trainer himself when he hears it.”

Theodorus: Not at all.

Socrates: “Or suppose that a meal is being prepared. The judgement of a waiting guest with no knowledge of cookery is inferior to the judgement of the cook about how pleasant the meal will be. So, let us not dispute about present pleasure or past pleasure for each person at this stage in the discussion. Let us discuss the future, and whether the person himself is the best judge of how things will seem, and what will be, and whether you, Protagoras, could at any rate anticipate better than any amateur, what speeches would be persuasive to any of us in a courtroom?”

178e

Theodorus: And, indeed, Socrates, he professed quite strongly to be better than anyone in that respect anyway.

179a

Socrates: Yes, by Zeus, dear friend, otherwise no one would have paid vast sums of money to talk to him. He must have persuaded them that no prophet, or anyone else, could judge better than himself how things will be in the future, and how they will seem.

Theodorus: Very true.

Socrates: Well, are legislation and benefit both concerned with the future? And would everyone agree that when a city

legislates it must frequently fall short of obtaining the greatest possible benefit?

Theodorus: Yes, indeed.

179b

Socrates: So, I think it would be reasonable for us to put it to your teacher that he must agree that one person is wiser than another, and that such a person is the measure, while I, in my ignorance, must not become the measure of anything at all, though the argument, entered on his behalf just now, compelled me to be a measure whether I wanted to or not.

Theodorus: I think his argument, Socrates, is defeated convincingly by that, and it is also defeated by giving authority to the opinions of others, opinions which state that, in their view, Protagoras' argument is not true at all.

179c

Socrates: An argument like this, Theodorus, that every opinion of every person is true, could be disproved in many other ways. But it is harder to grasp the untruth of the immediate experience of each person, from which perceptions and opinions about it arise. But perhaps I am talking nonsense and these cannot actually be challenged, and those who say that perceptions are self-evident and constitute knowledge may be describing the way things are, and Theaetetus here was not far wide of the mark in proposing that knowledge and perception are the same. So we should get closer and inspect this moving being, as Protagoras' proxy argument directs us, and tap it and test whether it rings hollow or true. Anyway, it is no minor dispute that has arisen over this, and there are quite a few participants.

179d

Theodorus: Yes, it is far from being minor. In fact, it is spreading all over Ionia, as the followers of Heraclitus lead the chorus for this argument most vigorously.

179e

Socrates: Well, in that case, dear Theodorus, we should consider it all the more from its very origin, just as they themselves present it.

Theodorus: Entirely so, Socrates. And in fact you could no more conduct a discussion on these Heraclitean doctrines, or the Homeric or more ancient ones you mention, with any of the Ephesians²⁸ who profess to be experts, than you could with madmen. Indeed, they simply keep moving as their doctrines say they should, while staying with a proposition or question, and quietly asking and answering in turn means less than nothing to them. Well, ‘less than nothing’ is an exaggeration, but there is no rest whatsoever in these men. Rather, if someone asks a question, they pull out enigmatic aphorisms like arrows from a quiver and shoot them off, and if you seek an explanation of something they have said, you get struck with a new piece of wordplay. You will never make any progress with any of them, nor do they get anywhere with one another, but they are very careful not to permit anything certain in an argument, or in their own souls, believing, I presume, that this is fixity, their worst enemy, which they try as best they can to banish from the world.

180b

Socrates: Perhaps, Theodorus, you have seen these men when they are being combative, and have not associated with them when they are at peace. Indeed, they are no friends of yours! But I think they do impart such matters, at leisure, to the pupils whom they want to make like themselves.

Theodorus: By heavens, what pupils? One of these fellows does not become the pupil of another. No, they grow up as they will and each of them takes inspiration from anywhere at all, and one man thinks that the other man knows nothing. As I was about to say, you would never get a rational account from these

people, either willingly or under compulsion. Instead, we must investigate the question ourselves as if we were taking on a mathematical problem.

180c

Socrates: Well, that sounds reasonable at any rate. Haven't we taken on the problem from the ancients, who used poetry to conceal from the multitude that the origin of everything else is Oceanus and Tethys, which are streams, and that nothing is fixed? Don't we have it from the moderns, who, being wiser, put on a more open display so that even cobblers pick up the wisdom of these men and give up their silly belief that some things are at rest while others are in motion, learn that everything is in motion, and come to respect these teachers? But, Theodorus, I had almost forgotten that others, for their part, proclaim opposite views to these. "All should only be called unmoving", they say. And there is much else that the opponents of these doctrines say, when, like Melissus²⁹ and Parmenides, they assert that all is one, established within itself with no place to move in. So what are we to make of all this, my friend? For moving forward, little by little, we have unwittingly ended up between the two sides, and if we do not defend ourselves and escape, we shall pay for it, like men playing in the wrestling ground who are caught by both sides and dragged in opposite directions across the line. Now, I think we should consider the people we began with, the men of flux, and if they appear to be talking sense, we shall help them to drag us to their side and try to escape the others. However, if the words of those who say that all is at rest sound truer, we shall fly to them, away from the men who move the unmoving. But if they both appear to be unreasonable, we shall be amusing in our belief that we common folk have something to say, when we have spurned the ancients and the utterly wise men. Well, Theodorus, do you think it is better to keep going in the face of such a danger?

181b

Theodorus: It would be quite unacceptable, Socrates, not to investigate what each of these groups is saying.

Socrates: Let us investigate it since you are so enthusiastic. Now, I think that our investigation of motion starts by considering the sort of thing people actually mean when they say that all things are in motion. I want to ask whether they mean there is one form of motion, or, as it appears to me, two forms. But this should not be my opinion alone. You should join in too, so that whatever the outcome, we go through the process together. So tell me, when something changes from one location to another or when it revolves in the same place, do you call that motion?

181c

Theodorus: I do, indeed.

Socrates: Then let that be one form of motion. But whenever something remains in the same place, yet grows old or goes from white to black or soft to hard or undergoes some other alteration, doesn't that deserve to be called another form of motion?

181d

Theodorus: I think so.

Socrates: So I am saying that there are two forms of motion – alteration and transposition.

Theodorus: And what you say is correct.

Socrates: So, having divided motion in this way, let us now engage in discussion with those who say that all things are in motion, and ask them whether everything exhibits both forms of motion, transposition and alteration, or do some things exhibit both, while some exhibit only one?

181e

Theodorus: By Zeus, I really cannot say, but I believe they would reply that everything exhibits both.

Socrates: Yes, my friend, otherwise for them everything will turn out to be both moving and at rest, and it will be no more correct to say that all things are moving than all things are at rest.

Theodorus: What you say is perfectly true.

182a

Socrates: Well then, since they must be in motion, and absence of movement is not possible for anything, everything is continually exhibiting every kind of motion.

Theodorus: It must be so.

Socrates: Now consider the following aspect of their proposition with me. Didn't we say that they propose something like this about the origin of heat and whiteness and the like, that each of these is moving, along with perception, between the active and the passive, and that the passive becomes a perceiver, but not perception, while the active becomes something with a certain quality, but does not become a quality? But perhaps 'quality' seems like a strange term that you do not understand from common usage,³⁰ so listen to a few examples. Indeed, the active element does not become heat or whiteness, but hot or white, and the same applies to all else. For I presume you recall what we said before, that nothing just by itself is one, neither an active nor a passive, but from the mutual association of both of them, perceptions and perceptible things are brought to birth, and the active become things with qualities while the passive become perceivers.

182b

Theodorus: I remember. How could I forget?

182c

Socrates: So let us set aside whatever else they say, whether it accords with this or not, attend only to this one topic of our discussion and ask them, “Do you say that all things are in motion and flux? Is this so?”

Theodorus: Yes.

Socrates: Now are they moving with both motions, which we defined as transposition and alteration?

Theodorus: They must be, if they are to be completely in motion.

Socrates: And if they were only transposed, and not altered, I presume we would be able to say what sort of things are being transposed in flux, or is this how we should refer to it?

Theodorus: Yes, this way.

182d

Socrates: But since this is not stable either, the flux does not flow white, but changes so that there is also flux of this very whiteness, and it transforms into another colour lest it be convicted of being stable in this respect. So how can we ever refer to a colour and call it by its proper name?

Theodorus: Yes, how can we do it, Socrates? Or how can we refer to anything else of that kind, if in fact it is constantly slipping away as we are speaking because it is in flux?

182e

Socrates: But what if we ask about any perception at all, like that of seeing or hearing? Does it ever remain stable as just seeing, or just hearing?

Theodorus: No, it must not, if in fact all things are in motion.

Socrates: So it should no more be referred to as seeing than as not seeing, nor should any other perception be called perception rather than non-perception, if all things are in every

kind of motion.

Theodorus: No, it should not.

Socrates: And yet, Theaetetus and I have stated that perception is actually knowledge.

Theodorus: Yes, that is what you said.

Socrates: So, when we were asked what knowledge is, we gave an answer that is no more knowledge than not knowledge.

Theodorus: It seems so.

183a

Socrates: The correction to the answer may turn out well for us who were so keen to show that all things are in motion, so that our original answer would prove to be correct. But now it seems to be the case that if all things are in motion, every answer that anyone gives on any subject is equally correct, whether it proclaims ‘this is so’ or ‘this is not so’, or if you prefer, we could say ‘becomes so’, in case we stabilise these fellows with the word ‘is’.

Theodorus: What you say is correct.

Socrates: Yes, Theodorus, except that I said ‘so’ and ‘not so’. But the word ‘so’ should not be uttered, for what is ‘so’ is no longer in motion, nor again should we say ‘not so’, for it is not in motion either. Instead, those who propose this doctrine must establish some other language, since they do not currently have words appropriate to their hypothesis, unless perhaps ‘not even thus’, an indefinite phrase, would best suit their purposes.

183b

Theodorus: Yes, that might well be the most appropriate language for them.

Socrates: Well then, Theodorus, we have freed ourselves from your friend and do not yet agree with him that every man is the

measure of all things, unless the man has understanding. And we shall not concede that knowledge is perception, not on the basis of the 'all things are in motion' approach anyway, unless Theaetetus here has another way of expressing it.

183c

Theodorus: I am glad you said that, Socrates, for with these issues concluded I too am freed from answering your questions, as we agreed, since the discussion of Protagoras' proposition has come to an end.

Theaetetus: No, Theodorus, not until Socrates and yourself have dealt with those who assert that all is at rest, as you proposed earlier.

183d

Theodorus: Is a young man like you, Theaetetus, teaching his elders to be unjust and break their agreements? Prepare yourself instead to respond to Socrates for the remainder of the discussion.

Theaetetus: I shall, if he wants me to. However, I would much rather listen to the other topic mentioned.

Theodorus: Calling Socrates into an argument is like calling cavalry to fight on open ground. So just ask, then sit back and listen.

Socrates: But, Theodorus, I do not think that I shall be persuaded to do what Theaetetus is asking.

183e

Theodorus: Why won't you be persuaded?

Socrates: I would be ashamed if we gave only cursory consideration to Melissus and the others who declare that all is at rest, but the shame would be greater in the case of the One – Parmenides. Parmenides appears to me, in Homer's phrase, to be at once 'venerable' and 'formidable'.³¹ Indeed, I met the man when I was very young and he was very old, and he seemed to

me to have depth and total nobility.³² I am afraid that we may not come to terms with what he said, and that his intention in saying so may escape us all the more. Also, the major topic that began this discussion – namely, what exactly knowledge is – may go uninvestigated if we allow this disordered influx of propositions, especially since the subject we are now raising is really immense and would not deserve to be investigated as a mere side issue. However, if we give it what it deserves, it will obscure our discussion about knowledge. So we should do neither. Instead, we should endeavour, through the midwife's art, to deliver Theaetetus of his conceptions about knowledge.

184b

Theodorus: Well, if that's what you think, that's what should be done.

Socrates: In that case, Theaetetus, let us consider this additional point in relation to what has been said. You gave an answer whereby perception is, in fact, knowledge. Is this so?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: Now if someone were to ask you, "With what does a person see black and white, and with what does he hear high and low pitch?", I presume you would say "with eyes and with ears".

Theaetetus: I would indeed.

184c

Socrates: A laxity in the use of words and phrases without any precise scrutiny is, for the most part, quite gentlemanly. Indeed, it is the opposite approach that is illiberal, though it is sometimes necessary, as in the present case, where we must take the answer you gave and consider a problem with it. Which answer is more correct, that the eyes are that with which we see, or by means of which we see? Are the ears that with which we hear, or by means of which we hear?

Theaetetus: I think that we perceive by means of eyes and ears, rather than with them.

184d

Socrates: Yes, my boy, it would surely be strange if there were lots of senses lodged inside us, like soldiers in the Wooden Horse, and everything did not converge on some single form, be it soul or whatever it should be called, with which by means of the senses, as if they were instruments, we perceive whatever is perceptible.

Theaetetus: Yes, I think it is better to put it that way, rather than the other way.

Socrates: Now, I am being so precise with you about this for the following reason: I want to ask if there is some part of ourselves that is the same, with which we conclude by means of the eyes that things are white or black, or by means of the other sense organs that things have various qualities. If you were asked, would you be able to refer all such processes to the body? But perhaps it is better that you give the answer to the question rather than me doing the job for you. So tell me, by means of what do we perceive hot, hard, light and sweet? Wouldn't you propose that it is by means of the body that you perceive each of them? Or is it by something else?

184e

Theaetetus: Nothing else.

185a

Socrates: And are you prepared to agree that whatever can be perceived by means of one faculty cannot be perceived by means of a different faculty, so you cannot see sounds or hear sights?

Theaetetus: How could I disagree?

Socrates: So, if you think something of both, you could not be perceiving them both through only one or the other of the

sense organs.

Theaetetus: I could not.

Socrates: Now in the case of sound or colour, do you first think this about both of them, that they both are?

Theaetetus: I do.

Socrates: And then, that each is different from the other, and the same as itself?

185b

Theaetetus: Indeed.

Socrates: And that both together are two, while each is one?

Theaetetus: That also.

Socrates: And can you also consider whether they are like or unlike one another?

Theaetetus: Perhaps.

Socrates: Now, by means of what do you think all these things about them both? Indeed, whatever is common to them cannot be apprehended by means of hearing or seeing. And there is also further evidence for what we are saying, for if it were possible to consider whether both are salty or not, you know you could say what you would use to investigate this, and that is evidently neither seeing nor hearing, but something else.

185c

Theaetetus: Yes, of course, it is the capacity that is exercised by means of the tongue.

Socrates: Well expressed! But now, by means of what comes the power to show you what is common to these, and to everything, including what you refer to as 'is' and 'is not', and whatever we were asking about just now? What sort of organ will you assign to all these, by means of which our perceiving part perceives each of them?

Theaetetus: You mean being and not being, likeness and unlikeness, same and different, as well as one, and number in general, associated with them. And obviously you are asking about odd and even and whatever else is associated with them, and you want to know the physical organ by means of which we perceive these with the soul.

185d

Socrates: You are following excellently, Theaetetus. Those are the very things I am asking about.

Theaetetus: Well, by Zeus, Socrates, I am quite unable to answer, except that I do not think at all that their source is some particular organ as in the other cases, but it appears to me that the soul itself, by means of itself, investigates what is common to them all.

185e

Socrates: You are a beauty, Theaetetus, and not ugly as Theodorus said, for he who speaks beautifully is beautiful and good. Indeed, as well as being beautiful, you have done me a favour by saving me from a lengthy exposition, since it seems to you that the soul investigates some things itself, by means of itself, and other things by means of bodily powers. That is actually what I was thinking myself, but I wanted you to think so too.

Theaetetus: Well, that's how it appears anyway.

186a

Socrates: Now, in which of the categories do you place 'being'? For it is surely common to everything.

Theaetetus: I place it among those things that the soul reaches for, just by itself.

Socrates: Along with like and unlike, same and different?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: And what about beautiful and ugly, good and bad?

Theaetetus: Yes, I think the soul considers the being of these in particular, in relation to one another, as it reflects within itself upon past and present in relation to the future.

186b

Socrates: Hold on! Won't the hardness of anything hard, and the softness of anything soft, be perceived by means of touch?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: But the soul, by reviewing them and comparing them to another, tries to determine for us their being, that they both are, and their oppositeness to one another, and again, the being of the oppositeness.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Now as soon as they are born, man or beast is naturally capable of perceiving whatever experiences are referred to the soul by means of the body. But reflection upon the being of these, and their benefit, arises gradually over time through much application and education on the part of those who actually attain it.

186c

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

Socrates: Now, can someone encounter truth who has not even encountered being?

Theaetetus: Impossible.

Socrates: And if someone does not encounter the truth of something, will he ever have knowledge of it?

186d

Theaetetus: How could he, Socrates?

Socrates: So knowledge is not in these experiences, but in the process of reasoning about them, for it seems that we are able to

apprehend truth and being in this way, but not through the experiences.

Theaetetus: So it appears.

Socrates: Well then, should you call them both by the same name when they are so different?

Theaetetus: No, that would not be right.

Socrates: Then what name do you give to the first, to seeing, hearing, smelling and feeling cold or hot?

186e

Theaetetus: I call it perception, Socrates. Is there another option?

Socrates: So you refer to it collectively as perception?

Theaetetus: I must.

Socrates: And we say it has no share in the apprehension of truth, for it has no share in the apprehension of being.

Theaetetus: No.

Socrates: Then, Theaetetus, perception and knowledge could never be the same.

Theaetetus: Apparently not, Socrates, and now it really has become abundantly clear that knowledge is different from perception.

187a

Socrates: But this was not the reason we embarked upon our discussion. Its aim was to find out what knowledge actually is, not what it is not. Nevertheless, we have made enough progress not to look for it in perception at all, but in what the soul is engaged in when it is concerned, just by itself, with things that are, whatever we call it.

Theaetetus: Yes, Socrates, and I believe this is called forming opinions.

187b

Socrates: Yes, your belief is correct, my friend. And now review this again from the beginning. Wipe all our previous discussion from your mind and see if you have a better perspective having made this much progress. Say once more what knowledge actually is.

Theaetetus: Well, Socrates, I cannot say that it is all opinions, since there is false opinion, so knowledge is most likely to be true opinion. Take that as my answer. However, as we proceed, if that turns out to be incorrect, as happened just now, we shall try another way of putting it.

Socrates: Now, that is how you should speak, Theaetetus, eagerly, rather than answering hesitatingly as you did at first. For if we act like this, there are two possibilities: either we shall find what we are pursuing, or be less inclined to think that we know what we do not know at all, and an outcome like that would actually be no poor recompense. So what are you saying now? Are there two kinds of opinion, one true and the other false, and do you define knowledge as true opinion?

187c

Theaetetus: I do, that's how it seems to me at the moment.

Socrates: Then is it worth taking up an issue concerning opinion?

Theaetetus: What sort of issue?

187d

Socrates: It is somehow bothering me now, and has done so many times before, generating great perplexity in relation to myself and others, since I am unable to say what precisely this experience of ours is, and how it arises in us.

Theaetetus: What are you referring to?

Socrates: The formation of false opinion. Thinking about it now, I am even more hesitant as to whether we should accept it, or investigate it in a different way than we did a while ago.

Theaetetus: Why not, Socrates, if it seems at all necessary? For what yourself and Theodorus said earlier about leisure was quite true, in matters of this sort there is no hurry.

Socrates: You are right to remind me, for perhaps this is not a bad time to retrace our steps. Better, indeed, to accomplish a little and do it well than to do a great deal but do it inadequately.

187e

Theaetetus: Of course.

Socrates: How shall we proceed? What do we actually mean? Are we saying that whenever there is false opinion, one of us forms a false opinion, while someone else, by contrast, forms a true one, as this is the natural state of affairs?

Theaetetus: Yes, that is what we are saying.

Socrates: Now, isn't each and everything we encounter either known by us or not known? Indeed, at the moment, I am omitting mention of the intermediate states of learning and forgetting, for they are not relevant to us just now.

188a

Theaetetus: Well, in that case, Socrates, there is nothing else left in each case, apart from knowing or not knowing.

Socrates: Then whoever forms an opinion must form an opinion, either about what he knows or what he does not know.

Theaetetus: He must.

Socrates: And, indeed, isn't it impossible for someone who has come to know something, not to know that same thing, or for someone who does not know, to know?

188b

Theaetetus: This must be so.

Socrates: So then, does someone who forms false opinions think that things that he knows are not those things, but different things that he knows, and having known both, does he then fail to recognise either?

Theaetetus: No, that would be impossible, Socrates.

Socrates: Well, could he think that things that he does not know are other things that he does not know, and is it possible that someone who knows neither Theaetetus nor Socrates could take a notion that Socrates is Theaetetus, or that Theaetetus is Socrates?

Theaetetus: How could he?

188c

Socrates: Nor indeed does he think that things he knows are somehow things he does not know, nor that things he does not know are things that he knows.

Theaetetus: No, that would be very strange.

Socrates: So how could someone ever form a false opinion? For it is impossible to form an opinion based on anything but these options, seeing that everything is either known or not known, but based on these considerations, it seems impossible to form false opinion.

Theaetetus: Very true.

Socrates: So then, we should not investigate what we are looking for in this way, on the basis of knowing and not knowing. Should we proceed instead on the basis of being and not being?

188d

Theaetetus: What do you mean?

Socrates: Perhaps it is as simple as this. Whoever, on any subject, is thinking things that are not, will inevitably form false opinions, whatever the general state of his mind may be.

Theaetetus: Quite likely, Socrates.

Socrates: But how? What would we reply, Theaetetus, if someone were to ask, “Is it possible for anyone to do what you are saying, and is there some person who could think what is not, either just by itself, or about some of the things that are?” And it seems we would say in reply, “Yes, whenever he thinks and thinks what is not true.” Is that how we would answer?

188e

Theaetetus: Just so.

Socrates: Now, does that sort of thing happen in any other instances?

Theaetetus: What sort of thing?

Socrates: Well, that a person sees something yet sees nothing.

Theaetetus: How could he?

Socrates: Well then, if he sees any one thing, he sees something that is, or do you imagine that one is ever included among things that are not?

Theaetetus: I do not.

Socrates: So a person who sees any one thing, sees something that is.

Theaetetus: Apparently.

189a

Socrates: And so, a person who hears something is hearing some one thing, something that is.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: And a person who touches something is also touching some one thing, something that is, since he is touching one.

Theaetetus: That is also true.

Socrates: And doesn't a person who is thinking, think some one thing?

Theaetetus: He must.

Socrates: And in thinking one thing, he is thinking something that is.

Theaetetus: I agree.

Socrates: So, a person who is thinking what is not, is thinking nothing.

Theaetetus: So it appears.

Socrates: However, a person who is thinking nothing, is not thinking at all.

Theaetetus: That seems obvious.

189b

Socrates: So it is not possible to think what is not, either just by itself, or about things that are.

Theaetetus: Apparently not.

Socrates: Then forming false opinions is different from thinking what is not.

Theaetetus: Yes, they seem to be different.

Socrates: So we have not found false opinion within ourselves based on this approach or the previous one.

Theaetetus: No, we have not.

Socrates: Then, does so-called false opinion arise in the following way?

Theaetetus: How?

189c

Socrates: We say that false opinion is a confusion of thought whereby someone says that one of the things that are is actually another of the things that are, having mixed them up in his mind. For in this way, though he always thinks what is, he thinks that one thing is another, falls into error in the investigation, and may properly be said to form a false opinion.

Theaetetus: What you have just said sounds perfect to me. For whenever someone thinks beautiful to be ugly, or conversely, ugly to be beautiful, then he truly is forming false opinions.

Socrates: Theaetetus, you obviously hold me in contempt rather than awe.

Theaetetus: What exactly do you mean?

189d

Socrates: I suppose you think I shall not pick you up on this ‘truly false’, and ask about the ‘slowly fast’ or the ‘heavily light’ or some other opposite, and whether it is possible for something to behave oppositely to itself, and not according to its own nature, but according to the nature of its opposite. Yet I shall let that go so that your spiritedness will not be in vain. However, you are satisfied, you say, that forming false opinions is a confusion of thought.

Theaetetus: I am.

Socrates: So according to your opinion, it is possible for the mind to posit that something is different from what it is.

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed.

189e

Socrates: Now, whenever the mind does this, mustn’t it actually be thinking of both things, or one or other of them?

Theaetetus: Yes it must, either both together, or in succession.

Socrates: Excellent! But do you call thinking what I call thinking?

Theaetetus: What do you call thinking?

Socrates: Speech that the soul itself carries on with itself about the matters it is considering. I am demonstrating my ignorance here, yet it seems to me that when the soul is engaging in thought, it is really engaging in discourse, asking questions to itself and answering them, and making assertions or denials. But when it has come to a determination, whether slowly or through sudden realisation, and it unwaveringly asserts the same thing, that we designate as its opinion. So then, I, for my part, refer to thinking as speaking, and opinion as speech, not spoken to another person or voiced, but delivered in silence to oneself. What do you say?

190a

Theaetetus: I agree.

Socrates: So whenever someone thinks of one thing as another, he also seems to be telling himself that one thing is the other.

Theaetetus: Indeed.

190b

Socrates: Now, try to recall if you have ever said to yourself that beauty is most assuredly ugly, or that injustice is just. In short, consider whether you ever tried to persuade yourself that one thing is in fact another. No, on the contrary, you have never dared, even in your sleep, to say to yourself that odd is even, or anything of that sort.

Theaetetus: What you say is true.

Socrates: And do you think that anyone else, sane or insane, ever seriously tried to tell himself, with any conviction, that an ox must be a horse or that two must be one?

190c

Theaetetus: By Zeus, I don't think so.

Socrates: Now, if speaking to yourself is thinking, no one who speaks and thinks of two things and is apprehending both with the soul, would say or think that one is the other. And you must allow me to use that expression, for what I mean is that nobody thinks that ugliness is beautiful, or anything else of that sort.

190d

Theaetetus: Yes, Socrates, I shall allow it and I agree with what you say.

Socrates: So when thinking of both, it is impossible to think that one is the other.

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Socrates: However, thinking about only one, and not thinking of the other at all, he would never think that one is the other.

Theaetetus: What you say is true, for in that case he would also have to be apprehending the one he is not thinking about.

Socrates: So confusion of thought is not possible, either through thinking of both of them, or of one of them. So then, anyone who defines false opinion as thinking that one thing is another would be talking nonsense, for there is evidently no false opinion in us, either on this basis or on the basis of our previous discussions.

190e

Theaetetus: It seems not.

Socrates: However, Theaetetus, if we cannot show that there is false opinion, we shall be forced to admit a number of absurdities.

Theaetetus: What sort of absurdities?

Socrates: I shall not tell you until I have tried to explore this in every way possible. Indeed, I would be ashamed on our behalf if

in our present difficulty we were forced to agree with anything I am saying. However, if we find what we are seeking, and become free, then we shall discuss this as something that happens to others while we stand aloof from the ridicule. But if we become utterly perplexed and humbled, I think we shall surrender to the argument and let it walk on us and do with us as it will, as though we had come down with an illness. Now listen, I find there is still one way of enquiry open to us.

191a

Theaetetus: Just tell me.

Socrates: I say that we were wrong when we agreed that it is impossible for someone to be deceived and think that the things that he knows are things he does not know, for in a way this is possible.

191b

Theaetetus: You are expressing what I suspected at the time, when we said that such a thing could happen. Is it that I, who know Socrates, see someone else at a distance whom I do not know and believe that person to be Socrates, whom I do know? For what you describe could happen in that way.

Socrates: Didn't we reject that idea, because it made out that we do not know the things we know when we have known them?

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

191c

Socrates: Well, let us not propose that but the following, which may be somewhat acceptable to us or may challenge us. But really, we are in such a state that we must thoroughly test every turn of an argument. Consider whether this makes sense. Is it possible to learn something that you did not know previously?

Theaetetus: It is, indeed.

Socrates: And then something else, and so on?

Theaetetus: Why not?

Socrates: Now assume, for the sake of the argument, that there is a block of wax in our souls, larger in some, smaller in others, some made of purer wax, others of more impure wax, some harder, others softer, while there are others with the proper balance.

191d

Theaetetus: I am assuming this.

Socrates: Let us declare that this is indeed a gift from Memory, the mother of the Muses, and that whatever we may wish to remember of what we see, or hear, or think up for ourselves, is stamped on the wax, like impressions on wax seals, by holding the wax under the perceptions or concepts. Whatever is imprinted is remembered and known for as long as its image may endure, while anything that is erased or that cannot get imprinted is forgotten and not known.

191e

Theaetetus: Let's accept that.

Socrates: Well, consider whether someone who has knowledge of things, and is considering something he has seen or heard, could form a false opinion in such a manner.

Theaetetus: In what manner?

Socrates: By believing that things that he knows are, at one time, things that he knows, and at another, things he does not know, occurrences that we improperly agreed to be impossible in our previous discussion.

Theaetetus: And what do you say now?

192a

Socrates: We must begin discussing the issues again, making the following distinctions. It is impossible for a person to believe that something he knows and has in memory in the soul,

and that he is not perceiving, is another thing he knows and whose wax stamp he also possesses, though he is not perceiving it. Nor again, can he believe that what he knows is something he does not know, and whose wax impression he does not possess. Nor could he think that something he doesn't know is another thing he does not know, nor something he does know. Neither could he imagine that something he is actually perceiving is another thing he is perceiving, nor that something he is perceiving is something he is not perceiving. Nor that something he is not perceiving is something else he is not perceiving, nor something he actually is perceiving. And furthermore, to believe that something he knows and is perceiving, and whose wax impression accords with his perception, is in fact another thing he knows and perceives, and whose impression accords with the perception, is even more impossible, if that is actually possible, than the other instances. And he cannot believe that what he knows and perceives and remembers properly is another thing he knows, nor another thing he perceives. Nor again, can he think that what he neither knows nor perceives is something else he neither knows nor perceives. Nor that what he neither knows nor perceives is something else he does not know. Nor that what he neither knows nor perceives is something else he does not perceive. All these instances compete in their inability to form any false opinion in anyone. Indeed, it is in the remaining instances, if anywhere, that false opinion must lie.

192c

Theaetetus: In what instances? Perhaps I would learn more from them, for at the moment I am not following.

Socrates: In cases where someone knows, but thinks the things are other things that he knows and perceives, or that he does not know but yet perceives. Or where he thinks what he knows and perceives are other things he knows and perceives.

192d

Theaetetus: Now I am even more adrift than before.

Socrates: Well, listen to this once more. I know Theodorus, and I remember within myself what he is like, and the same applies to Theaetetus. At certain times I see them, and sometimes I do not. At times I touch them, and other times not, or I hear them, or have other perceptions of them, while at other times I have no perception of them whatsoever. But do I remember you, nonetheless, and do I know you within myself?

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

192e

Socrates: Now this is the first point I wish to make clear, that someone can perceive or not perceive the things he knows.

Theaetetus: True.

Socrates: And in the case of things he does not know, he frequently cannot perceive them either, but often he can merely perceive them.

Theaetetus: This is true also.

Socrates: Let us see if you can follow me better now. If Socrates knows Theodorus and Theaetetus, but sees neither of them, nor has he any other present perception of them, he would never form an opinion within himself that Theaetetus is Theodorus. Am I making any sense?

193a

Theaetetus: Yes, this is true.

Socrates: Now this was the first of these instances I referred to.

Theaetetus: It was indeed.

Socrates: Then the second instance is that knowing one of you, not knowing the other, and perceiving neither of you, I would never think that the one I know is the one I do not know.

Theaetetus: Correct.

Socrates: And thirdly, neither knowing nor perceiving either of you, I would not believe that one whom I do not know is another whom I do not know. Now, assume you have heard again all the previous instances in which I never form a false opinion about you and Theodorus, if I know you both, or do not know you both, or if I know one and not the other. And the same argument applies to perceiving. Do you follow?

193b

Theaetetus: I follow.

Socrates: Then what remains is the formation of false opinion in cases where I know you and Theodorus, and have the imprints of both of you in that wax, just like the impressions from seals. Seeing you both from afar, but not very well, I hurry to match your particular imprint to your particular visual appearance, by fitting it precisely onto its own trace in memory in order to bring about recognition. But I get these wrong, and just like people who put their shoes on the wrong feet, I swap them around and set the appearance of one against the imprint of the other. Or my error is like what happens to the appearance of things in mirrors where left turns into right, and it is in these cases that varieties in opinion, and false opinion, occur.

193d

Theaetetus: That is quite likely, Socrates. You are giving a wonderful account of what happens to opinion.

Socrates: There is also the case where I know both of you and I am perceiving one and not the other, but my perception of the former does not accord with my knowledge. This is the case I was describing earlier, when you did not understand me.

Theaetetus: No, I did not.

193e

Socrates: Well, I was saying that if you know someone and perceive them and your knowledge of them accords with your perception, you will never think they are someone else whom you know and perceive, the knowledge of whom also, in turn, accords with your perception. Was that the point?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: What remains, I presume, is the current formulation in which we say that false opinion arises for someone who knows both of you, and sees or has some other perception of both without having the wax imprints in accord with his perception of them. And so he shoots wide of the target like a poor archer and misses the mark, and we have come to refer to this as falsehood.

194a

Theaetetus: And properly so.

Socrates: And whenever there is present perception corresponding to one of the imprints, but not to another, and the one whose perception is absent is matched with the present perception, in all these cases the mind is deceived. To sum up, in cases where one does not know, and has perceived, it seems there is no possibility of deception or false opinion if what we are saying is in any way sound. But it is in the particular cases where we both know and perceive that opinion twists and turns and becomes true or false, being true when it directly associates things in line with the proper impressions and imprints, but false when it goes crosswise to the wrong ones.

194b

Theaetetus: Isn't that beautifully described, Socrates?

194c

Socrates: When you have heard what is coming next you will say so all the more. Indeed, forming opinions is beautiful when they are true, but shameful when they are false.

Theaetetus: This must be so.

Socrates: Now they say that these differences arise in the following way. When the wax in a person's soul is deep and plentiful, smooth and evenly wrought, and the perceptions that come in through the senses are impressed upon this waxen heart of the soul, as Homer poetically calls its resemblance to wax,³³ then the impressions generated by the perceptions are clear, and as they have sufficient depth, they are enduring. And such people learn easily and then remember, since they do not confuse the imprints from the perceptions, but form opinions that are true. As the imprints are also clear and have abundant space, they quickly assign them to their own individual impressions, that are called things that are, and these people are called wise. Don't you agree?

194d

Theaetetus: I couldn't agree more.

194e

Socrates: But when a person's heart is rugged, a condition praised by the all-wise poet, or when it is sullied or made from impure wax, or is extremely soft or hard, those with soft wax learn readily but are prone to forgetfulness, while the opposite applies to those with hard wax. Those who have rugged and coarse hearts, somewhat stony with plentiful admixture of earth and filth, retain unclear impressions. And anyone whose wax is hard also retains unclear impressions, as there is no depth in them, while if their wax is soft the impressions quickly become indistinct as they melt into one another. And if, besides all this, they are jumbled together due to the confined space in someone's tiny little soul, they are even more unclear. All these people are inclined to form false opinions, for whenever they see or hear or think of anything, they are unable to assign it quickly to its proper imprint. Instead, they are slow, and as they assign them incorrectly, they mis-see, mishear and misconceive

most things, and are said, in turn, to be ignorant and deceived about things that are.

195a

Theaetetus: You are describing these men very accurately, Socrates.

195b

Socrates: So should we say that there are false opinions within us?

Theaetetus: Definitely.

Socrates: And true opinions?

Theaetetus: True also.

Socrates: Now, at this stage, do we think we have reached adequate agreement that there really are these two kinds of opinion?

Theaetetus: Very much so.

Socrates: But, Theaetetus, a talkative man is inclined to be truly formidable and disagreeable!

Theaetetus: Why? What are you talking about?

Socrates: I am annoyed about my own stupidity and how truly verbose I am. Indeed, what other word could you use for someone who drags discussions this way and that, and cannot be convinced because he is stupid and is hard to tear away from any proposal?

195c

Theaetetus: Oh, but why are you annoyed?

Socrates: Not only am I annoyed, but I am fearful about how I would respond if someone were to ask me, “Socrates, have you really discovered false opinion, that it lies neither in the relation of perceptions to one another, nor in the interrelationship of thoughts, but in the connection between

perception and thought?” I think I would agree, priding myself as though we had made a fine discovery.

195d

Theaetetus: Well, Socrates, I don’t think we need be ashamed of what we have just demonstrated.

Socrates: “In that case,” says he, “does that mean that we shall never believe that a man, whom we only think of but do not see, is a horse, which we neither see nor touch but only think of, though we perceive nothing else about it?” I presume I shall confirm that this is what we mean.

Theaetetus: And rightly so.

Socrates: “Well then,” he continues, “based on this account, one could never believe that the eleven that one merely thinks of are twelve, which again one merely thinks of.” Come on, you give the response this time.

195e

Theaetetus: Well, I reply that someone who is seeing them or touching them may think that the eleven are twelve. However, he would never form that opinion about the numbers which he holds in mind.

Socrates: What about this? Do you think anyone ever considered five and seven within himself, and I do not mean that he has five men and seven men in front of him or anything like that; I mean just five and seven themselves, which we say have memorial imprints in the wax, and cannot be the subject of false opinion? Now, if someone considered these numbers themselves, talking to himself and asking how much precisely they are, would one person say and think it is eleven, while another says twelve, or would everyone say and think that it is twelve?

196a

Theaetetus: No, by Zeus, there are obviously many who would say eleven, and in the case of larger numbers there are more errors, for I presume you are talking about all numbers.

196b

Socrates: Yes, your presumption is correct. Now consider what is happening in this instance, and whether twelve itself, imprinted on the wax, is thought to be eleven.

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Socrates: Hasn't our discussion arrived back at the initial proposals? For anyone involved in this error believes that something he knows is another thing that he also knows, and we said that this is impossible. Indeed, this was the very point which forced us to deny that there can be false opinion, lest the same person be constrained to know and not know the same things at the same time.

196c

Theaetetus: Very true.

Socrates: In that case, we must explain the formation of false opinion in some other way than by the misalignment of thought relative to perception. For if it was this, we would never be deceived in the internal thoughts themselves. But now, either there is actually no false opinion or it is possible for a person not to know the things which he knows. Which of these options would you choose?

Theaetetus: You are presenting an impossible choice, Socrates.

196d

Socrates: And yet the argument is not going to permit both of them. Nonetheless, should we risk everything and try something audacious?

Theaetetus: How?

Socrates: Let us decide to state what knowing is actually like.

Theaetetus: What is so audacious about that?

Socrates: You seem not to appreciate that our entire discourse from the beginning has been a search for knowledge on the basis that we do not know what it actually is.

Theaetetus: I do appreciate this.

Socrates: Then does it not seem audacious to be elucidating what knowing is like without knowing what knowledge is? But in fact, Theaetetus, we have been infected for some time by impure discourse. For we have repeatedly said ‘we realise’ and ‘we do not realise’, ‘we know’ and ‘we do not know’, as if we understood one another, though we still did not know about knowledge. Even now, if you don’t mind, at this very moment we resorted again to ‘not knowing’ and ‘understanding’, as if it were appropriate for us to use them, when we are actually deprived of knowledge.

196e

Theaetetus: But how could you conduct discourse at all, Socrates, if you avoided these phrases?

197a

Socrates: Well, I couldn’t, being the man I am, unless I was an argumentative fellow, the sort of man who, if he were here now, would tell us to avoid these phrases and would rebuke us fiercely for the deficiencies I am referring to. But since we are ordinary folk, would you like me to venture a statement on what knowing is like? It appears to me that this might be of some assistance.

Theaetetus: Venture away, by Zeus, and you will be generously forgiven if you do not avoid these phrases.

Socrates: Well, have you heard what they declare that knowing is these days?

Theaetetus: I probably have but I cannot recall just now.

197b

Socrates: I believe they say that it is ‘having knowledge’.

Theaetetus: True.

Socrates: Now, we shall change it slightly and say ‘the acquisition of knowledge’.

Theaetetus: But how can you say that this is different from the other wording?

Socrates: Perhaps it is not, but when you have heard what I think, then we shall examine it together.

Theaetetus: Yes, if I am actually able to.

Socrates: Well, having does not appear to me to be the same as acquiring. For example, if someone buys a cloak and it is at his disposal but he does not wear it, we would say that he has acquired it but does not have it.³⁴

Theaetetus: Quite right.

Socrates: Look now, is it also possible on this basis to acquire knowledge and not have it, just as if someone had captured wild birds, pigeons or the like, and provided an aviary at his home and reared them, we would probably say that in a certain sense he always has them because he has acquired them. Is this so?

197c

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: And yet in another sense he does not have any of them but he has gained power over them, since he has made them available in an enclosure at home to catch and hold whenever he wishes, capturing the one he wants and releasing it again, and being able to do this as often as he wants.

197d

Theaetetus: This is so.

Socrates: Again, just as we provided the souls with some undefined lump of wax in our previous discussion, we are now building an aviary for a great variety of birds in each soul. Some of these are arranged in flocks and they keep apart from the rest, others form smaller groups, while some birds are solitary and fly as they will among all their fellows.

Theaetetus: Let the aviary be built. What happens next?

197e

Socrates: Well, we should say that while we are infants this structure is empty, and we should appreciate that the birds are things which are known. A person who has acquired knowledge confines it in the enclosure, and we say that he has learned or discovered the matter of which this is the knowledge, and that is what knowing is.

Theaetetus: So be it.

Socrates: Now, consider the process by which we recapture this knowledge whenever we wish, retain it, and then let it go again. Consider whether these deserve the same name as the initial acquisition, or a different name. You may understand my meaning more clearly from this example. Is there a subject you call arithmetic?

198a

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: Now, assume that this is a hunt for items of knowledge about all odd or even numbers.

Theaetetus: I am assuming this.

Socrates: And I presume that, by means of this subject, a man has items of knowledge about number at his disposal, and also transmits them to someone else.

198b

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: And we refer to transmitting as teaching, apprehending as learning, and having an acquisition within that aviary as knowing.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Now pay attention to the following. Will the arithmetician who is perfect have knowledge of all number and nothing less, since he has the details of the knowledge of all numbers in his soul?

Theaetetus: Of course.

Socrates: Well, would a man like this, in mind, ever enumerate anything, either the numbers themselves, or external objects which have number?

198c

Theaetetus: Of course.

Socrates: And we shall propose that enumeration is the process of finding out what the relevant number actually is.

Theaetetus: It is.

Socrates: So we have agreed that this man knows all number, and yet he is trying to find out what he knows, as if he did not know it. Indeed, I presume you are aware of such contradictory statements.

Theaetetus: Yes, I am.

198d

Socrates: Now, when we compared this to the acquisition and hunting of pigeons, we said that the hunt had two aspects. The first is prior to the acquisition for the sake of acquiring something, and then, once acquired, there is capturing and having to hand whatever had previously been acquired. And in this way too, it is possible for a man to learn the same things again, things of which he had previous knowledge, having

learned them and known them. Can't he take up the knowledge of each of them again and retain it, knowledge which he does not have immediately in mind?

Theaetetus: True.

198e

Socrates: This is what I was asking earlier. What terms should be used to describe the arithmetician who sets about calculating, or the grammarian who goes to read something? In such cases, is a person who knows, going to learn again for himself that which he already knows?

Theaetetus: That would be strange, Socrates.

199a

Socrates: But should we say that he is going to read or compute things which he does not know, when we have conceded that he knows all letters and all numbers?

Theaetetus: No, that too is unreasonable.

Socrates: Well, would you like us to say that we do not care about names, and that someone can drag knowing and learning wherever they please? But since we have defined the acquisition of knowledge as one thing, and having it as another, it is impossible for someone not to have acquired that which he has acquired, and consequently it never happens that someone does not know that which he knows. However, we do say that it is possible to pick up a false opinion about it, for it is possible not to hold the knowledge of that, but another knowledge instead. This happens when someone is on the hunt for an item of knowledge which is flying about the aviary, but mistakenly grabs a different one instead of the one he wanted. So, in the case where he thought that the eleven was twelve, he had caught within himself the knowledge of the eleven rather than the twelve, like catching a dove instead of a pigeon.

199b

Theaetetus: Yes, that makes sense.

Socrates: But, whenever he catches what he is trying to catch, he is unerring and he thinks things that are. And so in this way there can be both true and false opinion, and the issues which troubled us earlier no longer present an obstacle. Perhaps you will agree with me, or will you take a different approach?

199c

Theaetetus: I take this approach.

Socrates: Well then, we are rid of the issue of people not knowing things that they know, for it can never turn out that we have not acquired the things we have acquired, whether we are deceived about something or not. But it seems to me that another more formidable issue is looming.

Theaetetus: What sort of issue?

Socrates: Whether the interchange of pieces of knowledge will ever give rise to false opinion.

Theaetetus: How so?

199d

Socrates: The first concern is that someone who has knowledge of something is ignorant of that very thing, not on account of ignorance, but on account of his own knowledge. Then comes the statement that he thinks that this thing is something different, and the different thing is this thing. Is it not very unreasonable that when knowledge is present, the soul knows nothing and is utterly ignorant? For based on this account, why couldn't the presence of ignorance enable us to know something, or blindness make us see, if knowledge ever really does make someone ignorant?

Theaetetus: Well, Socrates, perhaps we went wrong when we proposed that these birds stand only for items of knowledge, and we should also propose that there are ignorances flying

around in the soul at the same time, and the seeker sometimes gets hold of knowledge and sometimes of ignorance concerning the same thing. He then forms false opinions on account of the ignorance, and true opinions on account of the knowledge.

199e

Socrates: I can hardly refrain from praising you, Theaetetus. However, you should examine what you have said once more. Now, let it be as you say, that someone who gets hold of ignorance will form false opinions, according to you. Is that so?

200a

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: Of course he will not think that he is forming false opinions.

Theaetetus: How could he?

Socrates: Indeed, he will think they are actually true, and he will adopt the stance of a man who knows on matters where he is in error.

Theaetetus: Yes, he will.

Socrates: So he will believe he is in possession of knowledge, not ignorance, because that is what he has hunted down.

Theaetetus: Obviously.

Socrates: Well, we are back again at our initial difficulty after a very circuitous diversion. Indeed, that disputatious man will laugh and say, "How does this work, my good fellows? Does someone who knows both believe that some item of knowledge which he knows is some ignorance which he also knows? Or does he know neither of them, and think that one which he does not know is another which he does not know? Or having known one and not the other, does he believe that the one he knows is the one he does not know, or that the one he does not know is the one he does know? Or again, will you go on to say to me that

there are additional knowledges about the items of knowledge and the ignorances, and that he acquires these knowledges and keeps them in some other ridiculous aviaries or in wax imprints? Does he know these as long as he possesses them, though he may not have them immediately at his disposal, in his soul? Well, are you going to be compelled to go through this same cycle indefinitely without getting anywhere?" How shall we respond to these questions, Theaetetus?

200c

Theaetetus: By Zeus, Socrates, I don't know what we should say.

Socrates: So in that case, my boy, was the argument right to rebuke us and show that we were wrong to set knowledge aside and seek false opinion first, something which it is impossible to understand until we have a proper grasp of what knowledge actually is?

200d

Theaetetus: As things stand, Socrates, we must believe what you are saying.

Socrates: So what are we to say that knowledge is? For I presume we are not going to give up yet.

Theaetetus: Far from it, unless you yourself have had enough.

Socrates: Tell me then, what definite statement can we make that involves us in the least selfcontradiction?

Theaetetus: The very proposition we tried before. In fact, it is the only one I have.

200e

Socrates: What is it?

Theaetetus: That knowledge is true opinion. Forming true opinions is, after all, a process which is supposedly free from error, and whatever arises on this basis is entirely noble and

good.

Socrates: The guide by the river bank says, “You will be shown the depth, Theaetetus”, and in this case, once we proceed with our search, perhaps something which turns up along the way may reveal what we are seeking, but if we wait, nothing will become clear.

201a

Theaetetus: You’re right, so let’s go ahead and consider this.

Socrates: Well, this will be a brief investigation, for there is a whole profession pointing out to you that true opinion is not knowledge.

Theaetetus: How is that? What profession?

Socrates: The profession of the wisest men of all, whom we call orators and advocates. For these men use their skill to persuade rather than teach, and they make people form the opinions they want them to form. Or do you believe that there are teachers so clever that they can adequately teach the truth about what happened to people whose money was stolen or who were otherwise assaulted to people who were not present? Can they do this in the little time allowed by the water-clock in the court?

201b

Theaetetus: I don’t believe that they can teach them at all, but they may persuade them.

Socrates: And don’t you say that persuading them is making them form an opinion?

Theaetetus: Of course.

Socrates: Now, when a jury is justly persuaded about matters that only an eyewitness and no one else could know, on that occasion they are judging from hearsay. They have caught hold of a true opinion, but haven’t they judged without knowledge,

having been persuaded of what is right, if their adjudication is actually sound?

201c

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

Socrates: But, my friend, if knowledge and true opinion are really the same, the best of jurors could never form a correct opinion in the absence of knowledge. So in that case, it seems they are different from one another.

Theaetetus: Oh, Socrates, I had forgotten something that I once heard someone saying, but I remember now. He said that true opinion along with an account is knowledge, while in the absence of an account it is outside the realm of knowledge. And whatever is without an account is not knowable – yes, that’s the very term he used – while anything that has an account is knowable.

201d

Socrates: Well said, but now explain how he distinguished the knowable things from the unknowable, for I may have heard the same things you have heard.

Theaetetus: Well, I don’t know if I can work that out. However, if someone else were to explain it, I think that I could follow.

201e

Socrates: Then listen to a dream in return for a dream, for I too imagined that I heard from some people that the primary so-called elements from which we and all else are compounded lack any account. For since each, just by itself, may only be named, and nothing else can be said of it, either that it is or that it is not, for in that case we would be assigning being or non-being to it, but we must apply nothing if we are to speak of itself alone. So we should not apply ‘it’ or ‘that’ or ‘each’ or ‘only’ or ‘this’ or the numerous other terms like them, for these are in circulation and are applied generally, being different

from whatever they are assigned to. But if it were possible to describe an element and it had its own particular account, it would have to be described without all of the others. But as things stand, it is impossible for any of the primals to be expressed in an account, for they can only be named, since name is all they have. But when things are compounded from the primals, their names are woven together just as they themselves are woven, and they generate an account, for the essence of an account is an interweaving of names. Thus, the elements have no account and are unknowable, and yet they are perceivable, while the compounds are knowable and describable and can be the object of true opinion. Now, whenever someone has acquired a true opinion of something, without an account, then his soul has arrived at the truth about it, but does not know it, for a man who can neither give nor receive an account of a thing is ignorant about it. But once he has acquired an account, all these other things can happen, and he is perfected in knowledge. Was your dream like that or was it different?

202c

Theaetetus: It was exactly like that.

Socrates: Are you satisfied then, and are you proposing that true opinion with an account is knowledge?

Theaetetus: Quite so.

Socrates: Well, Theaetetus, have we really captured something this very day that generations of wise men have sought and grown old without finding?

202d

Theaetetus: Socrates, I really believe that what we have just said is an excellent description.

Socrates: And that is quite likely so, for what knowledge could there be in the absence of an account and true opinion?

However, there is one thing we said which is bothering me.

Theaetetus: What is it?

Socrates: What seems like the cleverest statement of all: that the elements are unknowable, while the class of compounds is knowable.³⁵

202e

Theaetetus: What's wrong with that?

Socrates: Well, we need to know, for we are holding the patterns of the argument like hostages, patterns used by the very person who said all this.

Theaetetus: What patterns?

Socrates: The elements and syllables of writing, or do you imagine that the person who said all we are recounting had something else in view?

Theaetetus: No, only these.

Socrates: Now let us test them, and let us test ourselves in particular, as to whether we learned writing on this basis or not. Well, in the first place, do the syllables have an account while the letters do not?

203a

Theaetetus: Perhaps.

Socrates: That is certainly how it seems to me. If someone were to ask about the first syllable of 'Socrates', and said "Theaetetus, what is SO?", how would you respond?

Theaetetus: That it is S and O.³⁶

Socrates: And isn't that your account of the syllable?

Theaetetus: It is.

Socrates: Very well, now give an account of S in the same way.

203b

Theaetetus: But how could anyone speak of the letters of a letter? Actually, Socrates, the S is one of the voiceless letters, it is just a sound like a hissing of the tongue, while B, for its part, has neither voice nor sound, nor have most of the letters. So it is quite appropriate to say they have no account, when even the clearest of them, the seven vowels, have a voice alone, but no account at all.³⁷

Socrates: So, my friend, we have come to this conclusion about knowledge.

Theaetetus: It appears that we have.

Socrates: But what about this? Have we really shown that the elements are unknowable, though the syllables are knowable?

203c

Theaetetus: Quite likely.

Socrates: Well then, are we saying that the syllable is both letters, or all of them if there are more than two, or is it a single form which arises from putting them together?

Theaetetus: I presume we are referring to all of them.

Socrates: Then consider two, the S and the O. This pair is the first syllable of my name. Can someone who knows the syllable avoid knowing both letters?

203d

Theaetetus: Of course not.

Socrates: So he knows the S and the O.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: Yes, but does he know both without knowing one or the other?

Theaetetus: No, that would be bizarre and illogical, Socrates.

Socrates: However, if it really is necessary for someone to know each letter if he is to know both, then anyone who is ever going to know the syllable absolutely must have prior knowledge of the letters. On this basis, our nice proposition has taken to its heels and fled.

203e

Theaetetus: And very suddenly too!

Socrates: Yes, we are not being careful enough with it. Perhaps we should be proposing that the syllable is not the letters, but a single form arising from them, having a single form of its own that is different from the letters.

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed, and that is probably a better suggestion than the other one.

Socrates: We should consider this, and not give up like cowards on a significant and serious proposition.

Theaetetus: We should not.

204a

Socrates: Then let our present statement stand, that a syllable is a single form which arises from joining the individual elements together, such as occurs in writing and in all other situations.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Therefore, it must not have parts.

Theaetetus: Why is that?

Socrates: Because the whole must be all the parts of anything which has parts, or do you also say that the whole is a single form that arises from the parts, and is different from all the parts?

Theaetetus: I do.

204b

Socrates: But do you refer to the entire and the whole as different from one another, or the same?

Theaetetus: I am not clear about that, but because you are asking me to respond readily, I'll take a chance and say that they are different.

Socrates: Well, Theaetetus, you have the readiness right, but we should consider whether the answer is right.

Theaetetus: Yes, we must do that.

Socrates: So wouldn't the whole be different from the entire, according to the current argument?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: What about this? Is there any difference between 'the entire' and 'them all'? For instance, when we say one, two, three, four, five, six, or twice three, or thrice two, or four plus two, or three plus two plus one, are we talking about the same thing or something different in all such cases?

204c

Theaetetus: The same.

Socrates: And is that different from six?

Theaetetus: No.

Socrates: Then, with each statement haven't we referred to all six?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: But if we say 'the entire', aren't we referring again to one thing?

Theaetetus: We must be.

Socrates: And is that a different thing from the six?

Theaetetus: No.

Socrates: So, in any cases involving number, do we refer to ‘the entire’ and ‘them all’ as the same?

204d

Theaetetus: It appears so.

Socrates: Then let us talk about them as follows: the number of a mile and a mile are the same, aren’t they?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: This also applies to the number of a furlong.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: Similarly, in the case of an army and the number of an army, and everything of that kind, the entire number is what each of them entirely is.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: But is the number of each, anything other than the parts?

Theaetetus: Nothing other.

204e

Socrates: And in so far as something has parts, it would consist of parts?

Theaetetus: It appears so.

Socrates: But we did agree that all the parts are the entire, if in fact the entire number is also the entire.

Theaetetus: So we did.

Socrates: Then the whole does not consist of parts, for if it were all the parts, the whole would be the entire.

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Socrates: But is a part, as such, part of anything other than a whole?

Theaetetus: Yes, of the entire.

Socrates: Well, you are putting up a brave fight, Theaetetus, but isn't the entire actually entire whenever there is nothing missing?

205a

Theaetetus: Necessarily.

Socrates: But won't that same thing from which nothing is missing be a whole? And that from which something is missing is neither whole nor entire; from the same effect, the same cause arises in both.

Theaetetus: It seems to me now that there is no difference between whole and entire.

Socrates: Were we not saying that for anything with parts, the whole and also the entire will be all the parts?

Theaetetus: Yes, indeed.

Socrates: Now, returning to my previous enquiry, if the syllable is not the letters, it must not have the letters as parts of itself, or else it will be the same as them and be just as knowable as they are. Is that it?

205b

Theaetetus: That's it.

Socrates: And to prevent this from happening, didn't we propose that it was different from the letters?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: Well then, if the letters are not parts of the syllable, can you propose other candidates that are part of the syllable, without, however, being the letters of the syllable?

Theaetetus: Certainly not, Socrates, for if I were to agree that it has some parts, it would be a bit ridiculous to ignore the letters and look for other candidates.

Socrates: Yes, entirely so, Theaetetus, based upon the current proposition, a syllable would be a single indivisible form.

205c

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Socrates: Now, my friend, do you remember a little while ago we accepted what we regarded as a sound proposal, that there is no account of the primals from which all else is compounded because each of them, just by itself, is uncompounded, and neither the terms 'is' nor 'this' can properly be applied to them as they describe different and distinct things, and this is the reason why a primal is indescribable and unknowable?

Theaetetus: I remember.

205d

Socrates: Well, is this the reason why it is uniform and indivisible, or is there another? Indeed, I can discern no other.

Theaetetus: No, it appears that there is no other.

Socrates: Doesn't the compound fall into the same category as the element, in fact it has no parts and is one form?

Theaetetus: Entirely so.

Socrates: So then, if the compound is many elements, and is a whole with the elements as its parts, the compounds will be just as knowable and expressible as the elements, since the many parts have turned out to be the same as the whole.

205e

Theaetetus: Certainly.

Socrates: But if, on the other hand, the compound is one and partless, the compound, like the element, will be just as indescribable and unknowable for the same reason. The unity and indivisibility will make them so.

Theaetetus: I cannot disagree with you.

Socrates: So we should not accept it when someone says that the compound is knowable and expressible while the element is not.

Theaetetus: No, indeed not, if we are persuaded by this argument.

206a

Socrates: Well then, would it be better to agree with someone who says the opposite, because of what you yourself discern in the process of learning to write?

Theaetetus: What do I discern?

Socrates: In learning to write, you have achieved no more than the ability to recognise each letter, just by itself, with your eyes and ears, so that its position in speech or writing does not confuse you.

Theaetetus: What you say is very true.

206b

Socrates: And isn't the perfectly trained lyre player able to follow each note and say what string it came from? And wouldn't anyone agree that these notes are the letters of music?

Theaetetus: They would.

Socrates: Now, if we had to generalise to others from the letters and syllables within our own experience, we would say that having knowledge of the elemental category is much more critical and important in the complete apprehension of each subject than knowledge of the compound. And if anyone says that the compound is knowable while the element is by nature unknowable, we shall assume that he is joking, either deliberately or unwittingly.

Theaetetus: We certainly will.

206c

Socrates: Now, I think even more proofs of this may turn up, but we must not forget the current issue because of them. We want to see what is meant by the statement that the most complete knowledge arises from the addition of an account to true opinion.

Theaetetus: Yes, we need to see that.

Socrates: Come then, what exactly are we supposed to understand by ‘an account’? For it seems to me to mean one of three things.

Theaetetus: What are they?

206d

Socrates: The first would involve making one’s thoughts manifest in sound, using verbs and nouns, forming the opinion into an image in the stream issuing from the mouth, just like an image in a mirror or in water. Or don’t you think that an account is something of that sort?

Theaetetus: I do. Anyway, we do say that a person who is doing this is giving an account.

Socrates: What is more, this can actually be done quite easily by everybody, so anyone who is not born deaf and dumb can explain what they think about every issue. This being the case, anyone who forms a right opinion will turn out to have that opinion with an account, and right opinion without knowledge will never arise at all.

206e

Theaetetus: True.

Socrates: Well, we should not be too quick to accuse the person who made the statement about knowledge, which we are now considering, of talking nonsense, for perhaps he did not mean this, but did not have the ability to give an answer in terms of the elements when asked what anything is.

207a

Theaetetus: Can you give an example, Socrates?

Socrates: Yes, it is like Hesiod referring to “the one hundred wooden parts of a wagon”.³⁸ Now, I could not say what they are, nor, I imagine, could you, but if we were asked what a wagon is, we would be satisfied if we could say “wheels, an axle, body, rails and yoke”.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: And yet, he might think we were ridiculous, just as if we responded based upon the syllables when asked what your name was. Ridiculous because, although what we said was correctly conceived and expressed, we thought we were grammarians who had a grammatical account of Theaetetus’ name and were expressing it. Whereas, it is not possible to give a knowledgeable account of anything until you can describe that by means of the elements combined with true opinion, as I think we said before.

207b

Theaetetus: Yes, we said that.

Socrates: Now, he will accept that while we really do have true opinion about the wagon in this way, someone who is able to describe its being by means of those one hundred parts, once he has also attained this, has added an account to the true opinion, and becomes expert and knowledgeable about the being of the wagon rather than merely opinionated, as he has described the whole by means of the elements.

207c

Theaetetus: Don’t you think this is sound, Socrates?

Socrates: Tell me whether you think so, my friend, and whether you accept that a description of anything based upon the elements is an account, while it is not an account if it is based on compounds or larger units. Tell me so that we can consider it.

207d

Theaetetus: Yes, I certainly accept this.

Socrates: And do you regard anyone as knowledgeable about something when he thinks that the same element is part of something at one moment, and part of something different the next, or when he thinks one element, and then a different element, belongs to the same thing?

Theaetetus: By Zeus, I do not.

Socrates: Then, are you forgetting that this is what you and the other boys did when you began learning to read and write?

Theaetetus: Do you mean that we first believed that one letter, then a different letter, belonged to the same syllable, or we placed the same letter sometimes in the appropriate syllable, and at other times in a different one?

207e

Socrates: That is what I mean.

Theaetetus: By Zeus, I certainly have not forgotten, nor do I regard people as knowledgeable when they are at that stage.

Socrates: What about a situation where someone is writing 'Theaetetus' and writes TH and E because he thinks he should, but when he goes on to try to write 'Theodorus', he writes T and E because he thinks he should?³⁹ Shall we say that this fellow knows the first syllable of both your names?

208a

Theaetetus: No, we have already agreed that when a person is at that stage he does not yet know.

Socrates: And could he be in a similar predicament about the second syllable, and the third and the fourth?

Theaetetus: There is no reason why not.

Socrates: Therefore, when he has a description based on the letters, he will write 'Theaetetus' with right opinion, once he writes it in the proper sequence.

Theaetetus: Obviously.

208b

Socrates: Isn't he still devoid of knowledge, though he is forming a right opinion according to us?

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: Yet he has an account along with right opinion, for he was writing using an approach by means of the elements, and we agreed that this constitutes an account.

Theaetetus: True.

Socrates: So, my friend, here we have right opinion combined with an account that should not yet be called knowledge.

Theaetetus: I'm afraid so.

Socrates: Well, it seems our wealth was but a dream when we imagined we had a perfectly true account of knowledge. But are we condemning it too soon? Perhaps an account should not be defined like this, for there were three options available to a person who defines knowledge as right opinion together with an account, and the last of the three still remains.

208c

Theaetetus: You are right to remind me. Yes, there is one remaining option. The first was an image of thought expressed in speech, the one we have just discussed was the approach to the entire based upon the elements. Now, what do you say the third option is?

Socrates: Exactly what most people would say it is – being able to express some indication by which the item in question is distinguished from everything else.

Theaetetus: Can you give me an example of an account of something?

208d

Socrates: If you wish. For instance, the statement that the sun is the brightest of the heavenly bodies moving round the earth would, I believe, be quite acceptable to you.

Theaetetus: Yes, certainly.

Socrates: Now, understand why such a statement is made, and in fact we have just given the reason. Once you understand the distinguishing characteristic by which something is distinguished from others, you will, some say, have obtained an account of it. But as long as you apprehend some common feature, your account will relate to whatever entities have this in common.

208e

Theaetetus: I understand, and I think it is appropriate to refer to this sort of thing as an account.

Socrates: Once someone with right opinion about any one of the things that are also grasps its distinction from the others, he will become knowledgeable about that of which he was previously just opinionated.

Theaetetus: So we say anyway.

Socrates: Well now, Theaetetus, since I have come closer to this statement, I understand it even less. It is like those shadow drawings which only seem to make sense as long as you stand far away from them.

Theaetetus: What do you mean?

209a

Socrates: I shall tell you if I can. I have right opinion about you, and if I also obtain an account of you, I shall actually know you, but otherwise I shall only be forming opinions.

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: But the account is an explanation of your distinctiveness.

Theaetetus: So it is.

Socrates: Therefore, while I was only forming opinions, I had no mental grasp of anything at all by which you are distinguished from others.

Theaetetus: Apparently not.

Socrates: So, I had some common qualities in mind that you, as well as anyone else, possess.

Theaetetus: So you must.

209b

Socrates: Come, by Zeus, in that case how did I ever form an opinion about you rather than anyone else? For I suppose I am thinking that this is Theaetetus, who is human and has a nose, eyes and mouth, and so on for each of the organs. Will these ideas themselves enable me to think of Theaetetus rather than Theodorus, or any out-and-out Mysian, as the saying goes?

Theaetetus: How could they?

Socrates: However, if I do not think only of people with a nose and eyes, but of those with a snub-nose and protruding eyes, won't I form an opinion, in that case, which applies to you as much as to myself or anyone else like us?

209c

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: In fact, Theaetetus will register no opinion within me until this snub-nosedness forms a distinct record imprinted within me, which is different from the record of any other snubnosedness which I have seen. The same goes for your other characteristics, and this imprint will act as a reminder if I meet

you tomorrow, and will enable me to form a correct opinion about you.

Theaetetus: Very true.

Socrates: So, in each case, right opinion would be concerned with distinctiveness.

209d

Theaetetus: Apparently.

Socrates: In that case, what more can the account add to right opinion? For if you say it adds an opinion by which something is distinguished from the others, then the process becomes quite ridiculous.

Theaetetus: How?

Socrates: When we have right opinion of things, by which they are distinguished from the others, we are asked to add another right opinion of the same things, by which they will differ from the others. So, the circuitousness of a roller, or a pestle, or anything like that, would be nothing in comparison to this process which may properly be called the directions of a blind man. Indeed, asking us to acquire what we already have so that we may understand the things about which we form opinions, is really and truly a deed of darkness.

209e

Theaetetus: Is there another option? What else were you going to suggest a moment ago?

Socrates: Well, my boy, if adding an account means knowing the distinctiveness, rather than having an opinion about it, our most perfect account of knowledge would be an oddity indeed. For knowing presumably means acquiring knowledge, doesn't it?

210a

Theaetetus: Yes.

Socrates: Therefore, it seems that when asked what knowledge is, this account replies that it is right opinion along with knowledge of distinctiveness, for that is what acquisition of an account is according to this.

Theaetetus: So it seems.

Socrates: And it is really quite simple-minded, when we are in search of knowledge, to say that it is right opinion along with knowledge, be it of distinctiveness or anything at all. So, Theaetetus, knowledge turns out to be neither perception nor true opinion, nor an account along with true opinion.

210b

Theaetetus: It seems not.

Socrates: Well then, my friend, are we still pregnant or in labour in relation to knowledge, or have we brought forth all there is?

Theaetetus: Oh yes, by Zeus, because of you I have spoken more than I had within myself.

Socrates: Isn't our art of midwifery saying that all these are wind-eggs and not worth rearing?

Theaetetus: Most emphatically.

210c

Socrates: Well, Theaetetus, if you attempt to conceive other thoughts in future, if you do conceive, you will be filled with better thoughts because of our present enquiry. But should you remain barren, you will be less oppressive to your associates, and gentler, as you will refrain, wisely, from thinking that you know what you do not know. This is as much as my skill can accomplish, it can do no more, and I know nothing that is known by the great and wonderful men of the past or the present. This midwifery has been allotted to me and my mother, by God, she for women, and I for the

young and noble and all who are good.

Now, I must go to the Royal Stoa to answer the charge which Meletus has laid against me.⁴⁰ But in the morning, Theodorus, let us meet here again.

NOTES

1. The dialogue's first two speakers, Euclides and Terpsion of Megara, were both followers of Socrates. Euclides is credited with having founded the Megarian school of philosophy.
2. Theaetetus was mortally wounded in the war between Athens and Sparta.
3. Cyrene, Theodorus' home town, was a Greek city in north Africa.
4. The Cape of Sounion marks the southernmost part of Attica, the territory belonging to Athens.
5. Socrates the Younger was a companion of Theaetetus, later a member of Plato's Academy. He is also mentioned in the two dramatic successor dialogues to the *Theaetetus* – the *Sophist*, in which he is mentioned briefly, and the *Statesman*, in which, together with the Eleatic Stranger, he is one of the main interlocutors.
6. A flat number is a square whose area is equal to the number, and so the side of the square, here called the line, is equal to the square root of the number. So, in the examples given, 3 as a flat number has a common measure with 4, but the side of the flat number 3 is $\sqrt{3}$, while the side of the flat number 4 is 2, and they have no common measure since $\sqrt{3}$ cannot be expressed as a fraction so as to yield a simple numerical ratio of 2. The term irrational is used to describe $\sqrt{3}$, but the entire process here is being described geometrically rather than arithmetically, and the lack of a common measure, called incommensurability, captures the essence of the problem. Contrast 4 and 9 where the sides (of the square) or magnitudes are 2 and 3, and so they have a common measure, and relate as $2/3$, as also do 16 and 36: $\sqrt{16} = 4$, $\sqrt{36} = 6$, $4:6 \rightarrow 2:3$. However, this process will not work with, for example, 15 and 36.
7. Socrates' mother's name means 'she who brings excellence to light'.
8. Artemis, goddess of the hunt and sister of Apollo, was the protectress of young animals and of women, particularly at the time of childbirth.
9. Aristides II was the grandson of a famous Athenian military and political leader of the same name. His education by Socrates is part of the subject matter of Plato's *Laches*.
10. Socrates describes his daimon as the usual sign that comes to him and always holds him back from something he is about to do. Plato, *Apology* 31c-e, 40a-c, 41d.

11. Prodicus, a contemporary of Socrates, was a distinguished sophist from Ceos who taught semantics and rhetoric. He is portrayed in Plato's *Protagoras*, and is mentioned in quite a few of Plato's other dialogues.

12. Protagoras of Abdera was a renowned sophist who taught rhetoric and virtue, and wrote several books. He is depicted extensively in Plato's *Protagoras*.

13. This seems to have been the title of one of Protagoras' books.

14. Parmenides from Elea in Italy, Heraclitus from Ephesus in Ionia, and Empedocles from Sicily were all influential pre-Socratic philosophers. Epicharmus was a comic poet from Syracuse in Sicily. Homer was a bard and epic poet, composer of the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*.

15. *Iliad* xiv.201, 302.

16. *Iliad* viii.17-27. Zeus says he could bind everything in a golden cord and tether it to Mount Olympus, leaving it to hang in mid-air.

17. The reference is to Euripides, *Hippolytus*, line 612. Hippolytus says of an oath he has made but not kept, "my tongue has sworn, but my mind is unsworn".

18. Hesiod, *Theogony* 265. Thaumás means 'wonder', and Iris is the personification of the rainbow and a messenger of the Olympian gods.

19. This is, in essence, the dictum attributed to Protagoras at 152a, with the addition of 'for me'.

20. Once a newborn baby reached five days old, it was carried round the family hearth as a symbolic introduction to the household gods and a request for their protection.

21. This is a reference to Protagoras' statement: "Concerning gods I am unable to know whether they exist or do not exist, or what they are like in appearance; for there are many hindrances to knowledge, the obscurity of the subject and the brevity of human life". Diogenes Laërtius, *Lives of Eminent Philosophers* ix.51.

22. Callias III, son of the richest man in Greece, was a student of Protagoras, Prodicus and Hippias, all prominent sophists.

23. Sciron was a legendary brigand on the coastal road at the Isthmus of Corinth. He had a reputation for kicking travellers off the cliffs into the sea, where they were eaten by a giant turtle. The hero Theseus, on his way to Athens, dispatched him in the same way.

24. Antaeus was reputed to have been a giant who forced all passers-by to wrestle with him. He drew his invincible strength from the earth, but was

finally defeated by Heracles, who lifted him in the air and then crushed him to death.

25. *Odyssey* xvi.121.

26. In law courts and elsewhere, speeches were timed by means of a water clock. Water flowed from one vessel to another and measured out the desired time.

27. Thales from Miletus in Ionia was the first of the Greek natural philosophers. He was an engineer, geometer and astronomer, and was counted among the Seven Sages.

28. The inhabitants of Heraclitus' home city of Ephesus.

29. Melissus, from the island of Samos off the coast of Ionia, was a pre-Socratic philosopher in the tradition of Parmenides.

30. This is the first usage of the Greek term *poiōtēs*, which literally means 'what-sort-ness' but is usually rendered in English as 'quality'.

31. *Iliad* iii.172; *Odyssey* viii.22, xiv.234.

32. This encounter, whether it is historically accurate or not, is depicted in Plato's *Parmenides*.

33. *Iliad* ii.851, xvi.554. The Homeric word for heart is *kear* or *ker*, which superficially resembles the word for wax, *kēros*.

34. The Greek verb for 'I have' can mean not only 'I possess', but also 'I have hold of it' or 'I have it on', e.g. in the case of an article of clothing.

35. The Greek word for element and letter is the same. The initial reference here is to a response based upon syllables rather than letters or elements.

36. Theaetetus actually says, "That it's sigma and omega", using the names of the first two Greek letters in Socrates' name.

37. The 'seven' are the seven vowels of ancient Greek, as contrasted with two classes of consonant – mutes like B, which cannot be pronounced without a vowel, and semi-vowels like S, which can.

38. Hesiod, *Works and Days* 456.

39. Socrates actually says, "he thinks he should write *theta* and *epsilon*", using the names of the Greek letters in the first syllable of Theaetetus' name. There are only two such letters because Greek represents the sound 'th' by the single letter *theta*. Moreover, this sound was a plosive (as in English 'fathead') rather than a fricative (as in English 'thin'), and so easy enough to confuse with 'te'.

40. The Stoa Basileios (Royal Stoa) housed the office of Athens' chief religious officer. Here Meletus made his formal accusation of impiety against Socrates in front of the King Archon.

Timaeus

ΤΙΜΑΙΟΣ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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narrator: TIMAEUS from Locri Epizephyrii, South Italy

persons in the dialogue:

CRITIAS of Athens

SOCRATES of Alopecce, son of Sophroniscus

HERMOCRATES of Syracuse

scene: house of Critias during the Panathenaea

17a

Socrates: One, two, three... But my dear Timaeus, where is the fourth of our banqueters from yesterday¹ who will now provide the feast?

Timaeus: Some illness has befallen him, Socrates, for he would not have missed this gathering deliberately.

17b

Socrates: Then you and your friends here have the task of supplying the part of the absentee.

Timaeus: Entirely so, and indeed we shall do our best not to be found wanting, since it would not be right if those of us who are left did not repay you lavishly when we were entertained with such fitting hospitality yesterday.

Socrates: Now, do you remember what I assigned you to speak about and what the topics were?

Timaeus: We remember some of them, but since you are here you will remind us of the others. Better still, if it's not a problem for you, go over them again briefly from the beginning so that we can be more sure of them.

17c

Socrates: So be it. I believe the discussions I was involved in yesterday were mainly concerned with the political system, what kind seemed best to me and what sort of men constitute it.

Timaeus: And what you said, Socrates, seemed very reasonable to us all.

Socrates: Didn't we first separate people engaged in farming or any other skills within the citizen-body from the warrior class?

Timaeus: Yes.

17d

Socrates: And so, based upon their nature, we assigned each a single occupation appropriate to themselves, one skill to each. We said that those who must fight on behalf of everyone else were the only ones who should be guardians of the city. And if anyone from outside, or even from within, should proceed against it with ill intent, they should judge them gently if they were our own subjects and natural friends, and harshly if they encounter them in battle among our enemies.

18a

Timaeus: Absolutely.

Socrates: Indeed, I think we said that something in the nature of the soul of the guardians must be both especially spirited but also philosophic at the same time so that it may be appropriately gentle or harsh to either party as required.

Timaeus: Yes.

18b

Socrates: What of their education? Aren't they to be educated in music and gymnastic and in all subjects proper to guardians?

Timaeus: Entirely so.

Socrates: Yes, and it was said, I think, that those who have been educated in this way would never regard gold or silver or anything else as their own private possession, but, like soldiers who receive their guardians' pay from the people they protect, in measure appropriate to sound-minded men, they would spend it communally and live shared lives together, careful to

ensure excellence in all their affairs whilst holding themselves aloof from other pursuits.

Timaeus: We said all that too.

18c

Socrates: What is more, we also mentioned women, and said that their natures would be formed like the men's, and all the responsibilities would be allocated to all the women on a shared basis, whether they related to war or to everyday life.

Timaeus: That too was stated.

Socrates: Now, what did we say about the procreation of children? Or is that easy to remember because what we said was so unusual? We proposed that all wives and children should be common to everybody, and we contrived that no one would ever recognise their own particular offspring, but they would all consider everyone else as their relatives, regarding them as brothers and sisters if they were within the appropriate age range, as parents and grandparents if they were older, and as children and grandchildren if they were younger.

18d

Timaeus: Yes, and as you say, that is easy to remember.

Socrates: But, of course, you also recall how they were to be born with the most excellent natures possible. We said that the male and female rulers must secretly arrange the marriage unions so that bad men and good men are assigned, by some lottery, exclusively to women of their own kind. No controversy would be created by this since they would assume that chance was responsible for the outcome.

Timaeus: We remember.

Socrates: What is more, we actually said that the offspring of good people should be reared, whilst the offspring of bad people should be secretly handed over to another city. However, as

they grow up, the rulers should be ever watchful to take the deserving ones back again, and let the undeserving ones among their own number take the place of those who have returned.

18e

Timaeus: So we said.

Socrates: So, dear Timaeus, now that we have gone over the main points once more, have we now recounted exactly what was said yesterday or is there anything we still need to say because it was omitted?

19a

Timaeus: Not at all, Socrates, these were the very things that were said.

Socrates: After all that we have recounted about the political system we have described, I would like you to hear the sort of feeling I have about it. Well, the feeling is something like this. It is as if someone who has seen beautiful animals, either in a picture or actually alive but remaining at rest, were to develop a desire to see them moving and also competing in a contest which seemed suited to their nature. I, too, feel just the same about the city we described. I would gladly listen to someone telling a story of contests the city engages in as it struggles against other cities, how it enters into war in the proper spirit and, in the conduct of the war, exhibits towards the various cities the qualities appropriate to its education and nurture both in its actions and negotiations, in what it does and in what it says. Now, in all this, Critias and Hermocrates, I have come to realise that I myself am quite unable to sing the praises of these men and this city adequately. In my own case, this is no wonder, but I have also come to have the same opinion of the poets, both ancient and modern. It is not that I disrespect poets as a class, but it is obvious to everyone that the imitative folk will imitate whatever they have been brought up in most easily and excellently. However, anything that lies outside their own

upbringing is difficult for them to imitate well in action, and even more difficult in words.

19e

Socrates: And I believe the sophists as a class, for their part, are very experienced in long speeches and other fineries. Yet, because they wander from city to city and have no city of their own, I fear that they may somehow misunderstand men who are at once both philosophers and statesmen, and all that such men would be able to do and say as they engage actively in war and fight battles or communicate verbally with others. What is left then is the class with your disposition, which, by nature and upbringing, possesses both characteristics simultaneously.

20a

Socrates: Indeed, Timaeus here is from Locri, the best governed city in Italy, and he is superior to any man there in property and family connections. He has been involved in the highest offices and honours of that city, and he has also, in my opinion, reached the very pinnacle in matters of philosophy. And I presume everyone in this city knows that Critias is no amateur in the matters we are discussing. As for Hermocrates, we must believe the many witnesses who say that he is competent in all these matters, both by nature and by his upbringing.

20b

Socrates: Now, this is what I had in mind yesterday when you asked me to speak about the political system in general, so I agreed readily since I knew that no one would present a better account of the next topic than yourselves, if you were willing. Indeed, you are the only men today who could engage the city in some suitable war and display all the qualities appropriate to it. So when I had finished speaking on my assignment, I, in turn, assigned you the topics I am now describing. So, having considered this together among yourselves, you have now agreed to pay me back with a feast of words. Here I am then, adorned for the occasion, and more ready than anyone to

receive your gift.

20c

Hermocrates: Yes indeed, Socrates, just as Timaeus here says, we shall not be short of enthusiasm, nor have we any excuse whatsoever for not doing as you ask. Accordingly, we considered these very issues as soon as we left here yesterday and arrived at Critias' guest quarters where we are staying, and even before that, on the road. In fact, he told us a story which he heard long ago. Tell the story to Socrates now, Critias, so that he can help us decide whether it is relevant to our assignment or irrelevant.

20d

Critias: That's what I must do if our third companion, Timaeus, also agrees.

Timaeus: I certainly agree.

Critias: Then listen, Socrates, to a story which is strange and yet entirely true, as Solon,² the wisest of the Seven Sages, once declared. He was a kinsman and close friend of our great-grandfather Dropides, as he himself also says many times in his poetry. Dropides then told it to Critias, our grandfather, and the old man, in turn, used to recount it to us. The story recounts that the ancient deeds of this city of ours were wonderful and great, but they have been obliterated by time and the destructions of humanity. It would be appropriate for us to recall one of these deeds now, the greatest of them all, in order to show our gratitude to you and, at the same time, to praise the goddess rightly and truly on her festival,³ as though we were singing a hymn.

20e

Socrates: That is all very well, but what was this ancient deed of this city of ours, a deed no longer mentioned, which Critias recounted on the authority of Solon as actual fact?

21a

Critias: I'll tell you an ancient tale which I heard from a man no longer young. Indeed, Critias was then, as he said, already close to ninety years old, while I was, at the most, ten. It happened to be the children's day of the festival of Apaturia,⁴ and the traditional event of the festival was also held as usual for the children, at which our fathers arranged a recitation contest for us. Many poems by many poets were recited, but since Solon's poems were new at the time, many of the boys chanted them. One of the clansmen said – either because he believed it or even to pay a compliment to Critias – that he thought that Solon was the wisest of men in every respect, but also, in view of his poetry, the noblest of all poets. Then the old man – yes indeed, I remember it so vividly – was very pleased, and he smiled and said, ^{21c} "Amynander, if Solon had not treated poetry as a distraction but had worked at it as others do and completed the story which he brought here from Egypt, and had not been forced to neglect it due to the conflicts and the other problems he found here when he returned, then in my opinion neither Hesiod nor Homer nor any other poet would ever have been more famous than he."

^{21c}

Critias: "What was the story, Critias?" he asked.

Critias: "It concerns the greatest deed this city has ever performed," he replied. "It deserves to be its most renowned achievement, but through lapse of time and the destruction of those who were involved, the story has not survived here."

^{21d}

Critias: "Tell it from the beginning," he said. "What story did Solon tell, and how did he hear it and who told him it was true?"

^{21e}

Critias: "In the Egyptian Delta," Critias said "near where the stream of the Nile divides at its estuary, there is a region called the Saïtic, and the largest city of this region is Saïs. King Amasis

came from there. The god who founded the city is called Neith in Egyptian, and those people say this is Athena in Greek. They are great lovers of Athens and they claim to be related to us in some way. In fact, Solon said that when he travelled there they held him in great respect. And what's more, on one occasion, when he put a question about ancient times to the priests with most experience of such matters, he discovered that, in a sense, neither he nor any other Greek whatsoever knows the slightest thing about them. Once, Solon wanted to draw them into a discussion about antiquity, so he began to relate the most ancient stories from Athens, about Phoroneus, who is said to be the first man, and about Niobe. And he went on to tell the story of the flood and how Deucalion and Pyrrha survived it,⁵ and the family histories of these people, and he tried to estimate the time periods by recalling the exact number of years since the events he described.

22a

Critias: "Then, one of the priests, who was a very old man, said, 'O Solon, Solon, you Greeks are ever children! There is no Greek who is an old man.' When he heard this, Solon asked: 'How can you say this?' ^{22b} "You are all young in soul,' the priest said. 'Your souls do not possess a single doctrine heard of old, or any teaching grey with age. The reason is as follows. There have been, and will be, many destructions of humanity by various means, the most significant being by fire and water, the lesser kinds by myriad other means. In fact, you Athenians also have the story of how Phaethon, the child of the Sun, once harnessed his father's chariot, but because he was not able to drive it along the path of the Sun, he brought fire upon the Earth and was himself killed by a thunderbolt. Now, this is told in the form of a myth, but the truth is that there is an alteration of the motion of the heavenly bodies travelling around the Earth, and at regular long intervals destruction is wrought upon the Earth's surface by an enormous fire. When this happens, those who live

in mountains or high places or dry places suffer greater destruction than maritime or river-dwelling folk.

22d

Critias: "The Nile, which is always our saviour, also saves us from this difficulty on such occasions by its rising. But whenever the gods flood the Earth with water to purify it, the shepherds and herdsmen in the mountains are saved, while those who dwell in your cities are swept out to sea by the rivers. However, in this land of ours, water does not pour down on the fields from above – not then, not ever – but on the contrary, it all comes up naturally from below. That's the reason why the records preserved here are said to be most ancient of all. The truth is that in all places where excess heat or cold do not prevent it, there is always a human race, sometimes in greater numbers, sometimes in lesser. And whatever events we hear about in your country or in ours, or anywhere else, that are somehow noble or significant or special in some other way, have all been written down in the temples here from ancient times and preserved.

23b

Critias: "But in the case of yourselves and the other cities, as soon as you have been equipped with writing and whatever else a city requires, every time, after the usual cycle of years, the flood from Heaven arrives once more, bearing down upon you like a plague, leaving only the illiterate and uncultured among you, so that you become like children all over again, with no knowledge of events of ancient times, either here or among yourselves. Take the genealogies you have just recounted about your own people, Solon. These are little better than children's stories. In the first place, you remember only one flood, though many occurred before that, and then you do not realise that the noblest and most excellent race in the history of humanity once lived in your own country. You and your entire city are descended from this race, from a small remnant of their seed,

but you are unaware of this because, for many generations, those who survived left no written records when they died. But there was once a time, Solon, before the greatest ever destruction by water, when the city that is now Athens was better than any in war, and supremely well governed in every respect. Its deeds were reputed to have been the noblest, and the conduct of its affairs the fairest of any city we have heard of under Heaven.' ^{23d} "When he heard this, Solon said he was amazed, and in all earnestness he asked the priests to recount everything about the ancient citizens of Athens, precisely and in due order. The priest replied, 'No one will grudge you this, Solon, so I shall tell you the story for your sake and for the sake of your city, but especially in gratitude to the goddess who has adopted, nurtured and educated your city and ours. Your city was first by a thousand years, taking your seed from earth and Hephaestus, while our city here came later. The civilisation here is recorded in our sacred writings as being eight thousand years old. So I shall be giving you a brief overview of your citizens from nine thousand years ago, their laws, and the most splendid of the deeds they performed. But we shall go over everything in detail and due order some other time at leisure when we access the actual records.

^{24a}

Critias: "Now, compare your laws with ours, for you will find many examples of your ancient laws in operation here today. Firstly, the priestly class is kept apart from the others. Then, the class of manufacturers works by itself and does not mix with another, and the same applies to herdsmen, hunters and farmers. What's more, the warrior class here, I presume you have noticed, is kept apart from all the other classes, as they are enjoined by law to be concerned with nothing except military matters. And even the style of our armour is based on shields and spears which we were the first people in Asia to adopt, as the goddess instructed us in this, just as she first instructed you

in your region.

24b

Critias: "Furthermore, I presume you observe the extent to which tradition in Egypt has been concerned, from the very outset, with wisdom and the Universe, discovering everything right down to prophecy and medicine for health by applying those divine considerations to human concerns, and mastering all other learning that derives from these. Now, this is, in fact, the overall structure and regulation which the goddess devised at the time she first founded your city, selecting the place in which you were born because she saw that the temperate climate there would produce the wisest men. Seeing that the goddess was a lover of war and a lover of wisdom, she chose the place likely to produce men who were most akin to herself, and there she first founded a city where you dwelt, adopting such regulations as these. Indeed, you were even better regulated, having surpassed all other peoples in every kind of excellence, just as you would expect from a people born from and educated by the gods.

24d

Critias: "Now, the numerous great deeds of your city that are recorded here are a wonder, but there is one which surpasses them all in importance and excellence. For our records tell how great a power it was that once surged forth from the Atlantic Ocean and proceeded violently against all of Europe and Asia at the same time, a power which your city stopped. In fact, the ocean in the area was navigable then, and there was an island in front of the strait which your people tell me they call the Pillars of Heracles.⁶ This island was bigger than Africa and Asia together, and it was possible in those days for travellers to get from there to the other islands, and from the islands to the entire adjacent continent which surrounds that real ocean. For these places that are inside the strait we are speaking of resemble a harbour with a narrow entrance, but the ocean

outside is a real ocean, and the land that surrounds it may truly and correctly be termed a continent.

25a

Critias: "Now on this island of Atlantis, a great and wonderful kingly power was established which ruled the entire island, many other islands and part of the continent. What's more, even within the straits, they ruled Africa as far as Egypt, and Europe as far as Tuscany. This entire kingdom once constituted itself as one united force, and tried in a single onslaught to enslave your land and ours, and indeed the entire territory inside the strait. It was then, Solon, that the power of your city shone forth before all mankind in excellence and strength, as it stood pre-eminent above all in nobility of spirit, as well as skill in military affairs. For a time it led the forces of the Greeks, but when the others had given up, it had to stand alone facing extreme danger, triumphed over the invaders, set up a monument, saved from slavery those who had not yet been enslaved, and ungrudgingly freed all the others who dwell inside the Pillars of Heracles.

25c

Critias: "Sometime later there was a huge earthquake and deluge, and there came a single grievous day and night in which your entire warrior class was suddenly swallowed by the Earth, and the island of Atlantis, in like manner, sank beneath the sea and disappeared. Because of this, the sea in those parts has now become impassable and unnavigable, since it is blocked, just below the surface, by mud which was left by the island as it sank."

25d

Critias: Now, Socrates, you have heard a shortened version of the account given by old Critias based on what Solon had heard. However, yesterday when you were talking about the political system and the men you mentioned, I was amazed to be reminded of the very details I have recounted just now, as I

realised that, miraculously, by some chance, your account was in broad agreement with what Solon had recounted. I was reluctant to say anything immediately, because it was a long time ago and I did not remember the story well enough. So I decided that I would first need to recollect everything properly for myself, and then tell the story. Accordingly, I quickly agreed to your assignments yesterday, being of the view that the biggest task in all such situations is to deliver a speech which fits the purpose, and that we were well equipped for this. So it was, as Hermocrates said, that as soon as I left here yesterday, I told these men the story I had remembered, and after I left them I went back over it during the night and remembered almost everything. Well, I tell you, as the saying goes, the lessons of childhood have an amazing grip on the memory. In fact, I do not know if I would be able to recall to memory everything I heard yesterday, and yet I would be completely surprised if any detail of that story which I heard so long ago has escaped me. I heard it with so much pleasure and delight at the time, and the old man taught me so enthusiastically because of my constant questioning, that it has become like burnt-in impressions of indelible writing abiding within me. And, in fact, I recounted these very details to our friends here first thing this morning so that they too would be well provided with stories to tell.

26c

Critias: So, Socrates, I am now ready to explain the reason why I have related all this, not just in summary only, but in detail, just as I heard it. We shall now transpose the citizens and the city which you described to us yesterday as a myth to a true situation by locating that city here, as if it were our city, Athens, and those citizens whom you imagined, we shall declare to be our true ancestors whom the Egyptian priest described. The two stories will harmonise completely, and we shall strike no discordant note in declaring that your citizens are the

Athenians of ancient times. Working together and with each taking a part, we shall all endeavour, as best we can, to present an appropriate response to the tasks you assigned us. Well then, Socrates, you must consider whether this account of ours accords with your intention, or we should look for another instead.

26e

Socrates: Why, Critias, what account would we choose in preference to this one, when it is so especially appropriate to the festival of the goddess because of its connection to her? And the fact that it is no invented story, but a true account, is all important, I presume. How and from where shall we ever find alternatives if we let these go? It's impossible. So you must speak, and good luck with it, while I must now remain quiet and take a turn at listening, in contrast to my speaking role yesterday.

27a

Critias: Behold the order of the feast we have arranged for you, Socrates. It seemed to us that Timaeus should speak first since he is the best astronomer among us, and has made it his principal task to understand the nature of the Universe. He will begin with the creation of the Universe and conclude with the nature of human beings. After this, I shall proceed as if I have received human beings from Timaeus created in his story, and from you some who have been specially educated, and bring them before us as if before judges, in accordance with Solon's account and his law, and make them citizens of this city of ours, since they are, in fact, the ancient Athenians whose disappearance was revealed by the record of the sacred writings. From then on they should be referred to as Athenians, our fellow citizens.

27b

Socrates: It seems that I am going to be repaid, fully and magnificently, with a feast of discourse. Apparently, it is your

turn to speak next, Timaeus, once you have invoked the gods in the customary manner.

27c

Timaeus: Well, Socrates, that is just what anyone with even a little sound-mindedness does before they embark upon any undertaking, great or small. They always, I presume, call upon God. And we who are somehow going to make speeches about the Universe, how it has been generated or whether it is actually ungenerated, if we are not to go entirely astray, must call upon the gods and goddesses and pray that everything be spoken acceptably to them in particular, and less importantly, to ourselves. Now, let that be our invocation to the gods, but we must also invoke that which is ours so that you may learn easily, and I may expound my thoughts on the subjects before us as best I can.

27d

Timaeus: In my opinion, we must certainly make this distinction first. What is 'that which always is' and has no becoming, and what is 'that which is always becoming' but never is? Now, the former, being ever the same, is comprehended by the activity of nous, together with an account, the latter by opinion, together with sense perception devoid of an account. It comes into being and passes away and never actually is. Again, all that comes into being must come into being from some cause, for it is impossible for anything to be generated without a cause. Now, whenever a craftsman, looking always to the unchanging, refers to something like this as his model, he will reproduce its form and character, and all that he fashions in this way will necessarily be beautiful, but if he looks to something that has come to be and uses a generated model, the product will not be beautiful.

28b

Timaeus: Now, there is something which must be considered first about the entire Heaven or Universe. In fact, let's call it by

whatever name it most readily accepts. This is a fundamental question that must be considered at the outset in relation to anything, whether it always was, with no beginning in generation, or whether it has come to be, having originated from some beginning. It has come to be, for it is both visible, tangible, and it has a body, and all such things are perceptible, and perceptibles are grasped by opinion and the senses, and, as we saw, come into being and are generated. What's more, we say that a thing which has come to be has, of necessity, come to be through some cause. Now, to discover the maker and father of this Universe is a task indeed, and, having discovered him, it is impossible to describe him to everyone.

28c

Timaeus: In any case, there is a question we must consider once more in relation to the Universe. With respect to which of the models did its artificer fashion it? Was it with respect to that which remains the same and unchanging, or with respect to a generated model? If, indeed, this Universe is beautiful and the craftsman is good, then clearly he looked towards the everlasting; otherwise, if that's not the case, although no one may legitimately say this, then he looked towards a model which has come to be. It is surely obvious to everyone that the model was everlasting, since the Universe is the most beautiful of created things, and the craftsman is the most excellent of causes. So, having come into being in this way, it has been made to resemble that which is comprehended by reason and intelligence, and remains the same. Furthermore, since this is the case, it is entirely necessary that this Universe be an image of something.

29b

Timaeus: Now, on every subject it is most important to begin at the natural beginning. So, there is a distinction we must make in relation to an image and its model. Accounts are also akin to the very subjects they expound, so accounts of anything stable

and certain and discernible by nous will be fixed and unchanging, and such accounts must be irrefutable and incontrovertible, and insofar as this is possible, appropriate for accounts, they should not fall short of this. However, accounts of something copied from that model, something which is therefore a likeness, are likely accounts, and stand in a relation to the other accounts; as being is to becoming, so too is truth to belief. Therefore, don't be surprised, Socrates, if in many cases on numerous subjects such as the gods or the creation of the Universe, we prove unable to furnish accounts that are entirely and in every way consistent with themselves and exact. Indeed, if we can offer an account that is as likely as any other, we should be content, remembering that I who speak, and you who judge, possess a human nature, and so, accepting the likely story about these matters, it is appropriate to seek nothing beyond that.

29d

Socrates: Excellent, Timaeus. Indeed, as you say, we must accept it unreservedly. We have enthusiastically accepted the prelude from you in wonder, so please proceed now to the main theme.

Timaeus: Well, let us state the reason why becoming and the Universe were constructed by the artificer.

29e

Timaeus: He was good, and in the good no envy ever arises about anything, and being devoid of envy he desired that all things be as much like himself as possible. We would then be absolutely right to accept from men of understanding that this is the supreme source of becoming and of the Universe. For the god desired that all be good and, as far as possible, nothing be imperfect. He therefore took everything that was visible, which was not at rest but moving discordantly and randomly, and he led it from disorder to order, regarding order as entirely

superior to disorder. But it was not then, nor is it now, lawful for the supreme to enact anything except the supremely beautiful. So, on reflection, he discovered that in the realm of whatever is naturally visible, nothing that is made without nous is, on the whole, ever better than something which possesses nous, and furthermore, that nous cannot be present in anything in the absence of soul. Based on this reflection, having placed nous in soul, and soul in body, he constructed the Universe so that, once completed, it would naturally be as beautiful and excellent a piece of work as was possible. Accordingly, based upon the likely account, we must state that this Universe is a living creature with soul and nous that has, in truth, come into being through the providence of God.

30c

Timaeus: This being the case, we should go on to state the next topics. In the likeness of which of the living creatures did the maker construct the Universe? Let us not degrade it to something which, by nature, is a part, for that is incomplete, and the likeness of something incomplete would never be beautiful. Instead, we propose that the Universe resembles, more than anything else, whatever all other species and classes of living beings, individually or on the basis of kinds, are parts of. In fact, that Universe contains within itself all living things that can be discerned by nous, just as this Universe contains us and all creatures which can be discerned by sight. The god wished the Universe to resemble the most beautiful and entirely perfect of all that nous perceives, so he constructed a single, visible, living creature containing within it all creatures that are by nature kindred to it.

31a

Timaeus: Have we been right to speak of one single Universe, or is it more correct to refer to many, indeed an unlimited number? If, in fact, it is to be crafted in accordance with the model, there will be one. For that which encompasses all living

creatures discernible by nous could not ever be one of a pair. If it were so, an additional living being would be needed to embrace both of these, and the two would be parts of this living thing. It would then be more correct to say that the Universe resembles not the two creatures, but the creature which contains them both. Therefore, so that it would resemble the all-perfect creature in respect of its uniqueness, the maker, accordingly, did not make two or infinitely many universes; rather, this only begotten Heaven has come into existence, and it is one, and one it shall be hereafter.

31b

Timaeus: Now, whatever has come to be must have bodily form and be visible and tangible, but nothing could ever have become visible without fire, or tangible without something solid, nor solid without earth. Hence, as he began to construct the body of the Universe, God made it from fire and earth. Now, it is not possible for two things to be combined well on their own without a third, for some bond is required between the two to draw them together. The very best bond is that which, as much as possible, makes itself and the conjoined entities one, and it is proportion that, by nature, best accomplishes this. So, whenever the middle item of three numbers or volumes or power is such that the first is to the middle as the middle is to the last, and again, that the last is to the middle as the middle is to the first, then the middle becomes first and last, and the last and first for their part both become middles. Accordingly, it follows, of necessity, that they all turn out to be the same, and since they have all become the same as one another, they will all be one.⁷

32b

Timaeus: So then, if the body of the Universe had to come into being having surface but no depth, a single mean would have sufficed to bind its constituents together with itself. But now, since it has a solid structure, and solids are never conjoined by

one middle term but by two, God therefore placed water and air between fire and earth, and insofar as it was possible he arranged that they have the same proportion to one another, so that as fire is to air, air is to water, and as air is to water, water is to earth.⁸ These he bound together and constructed a visible and tangible Heaven. And, for these reasons and from such constituents as these – four in number – the body of the Universe was generated, having been harmonised by proportion and endowed from these with affection, so that having come to sameness with itself, it was rendered indissoluble by anyone except the one who conjoined it.

32c

Timaeus: Now, the construction of the Universe actually consumed each one of these four elements entirely. For the artificer constructed it from all of the fire and water, and also the air and earth, not one part, or power, of any of them being left outside of it. He decided this for the following reasons: firstly so that it would be as whole and perfect a living being as possible, made from perfect parts; in addition to this, it was to be one, since there would be nothing left over from which something else of this kind could be generated. It was also to be free from old age and disease, as he realised that if a composite body is surrounded by heat or cold, or any powerful forces outside it, they attack it and bring it to an untimely end, and by inducing disease and old age they make it waste away.

33b

Timaeus: So, for this reason, and based upon this consideration, he fashioned it whole, composed of all these wholes – one, perfect, ageless and incorruptible – and he gave a shape to it that was appropriate and belonged to its nature. The shape, which contains all other shapes within itself, was appropriate for the living being that is going to embrace all other living beings within itself, so he turned it to make it circular, a spherical shape having all of its extremities equidistant from its

centre. This is the most perfect of all shapes and the one most uniform with itself, and uniformity he regarded as infinitely better than non-uniformity. And so, he polished it all smooth and round on the outside for many reasons.

33c

Timaeus: It had no need of eyes, for there was nothing to be seen outside it, nor hearing, for there was nothing to be heard. There was no air around about it which it needed to breathe, nor did it require any organ by which it might receive food into itself, or indeed expel it again once it had been digested. In fact, nothing went out or came in from anywhere, for there was nothing. Indeed, it was contrived by design so as to provide its own food from its own waste, and to experience everything within itself and enact everything by itself, because he who assembled it thought it would be better for it to be self-sufficient rather than being dependent on others. He did not think it necessary to attach hands to it when they were not needed to grasp with or to ward off anything, nor feet neither, nor any support to stand upon, for he assigned it a movement natural to its body, the most reasonable and intelligent of the seven kinds of motion. Accordingly, he caused it to move by revolving in a circle, leading it around in the same way, in the same place, within itself, and he took all the other six motions away and fashioned it without their wanderings.⁹ Seeing that it did not need feet for this circular motion, he brought it forth without legs or feet.

34a

Timaeus: This was the entire thinking of the god who is always about the god that was soon to be, and based on this thinking he made it smooth and uniform, everywhere equal from the centre, a complete perfect body composed of perfect bodies. He placed soul in the middle of it and stretched it through the entire body, and even covered the outside of the body with it, and established one single, solitary, round Heaven revolving in

a circle. It was able, because of its excellence, to interact with itself, having no need of any other as it was acquaintance and friend enough to itself. For all these reasons, what he created was a blessed god.

34c

Timaeus: But although we are now endeavouring to speak of the soul after our description of the body, the god did not, accordingly, contrive that the soul be younger, for when he combined them he would not have allowed the elder to be ruled by the younger. But we, with our accustomed degree of casualness, speak in this somewhat random fashion. In fact, he constructed the soul to be elder and prior to the body in birth and in excellence, its mistress and ruler.

35a

Timaeus: He made the soul from the following constituents and in this manner. From being that is undivided and ever the same, and being which, by contrast, comes into existence apportioned to bodies, he formed a third intermediate form of being from both of them. From the nature of same and other, in like manner, he made a third intermediate form between their undivided form and their form as apportioned to bodies. He then took these three mixtures¹⁰ and mixed them all into one, and as the nature of other was difficult to mix, he blended it with same by force. Then, having mixed this, with the help of Being, and made one from the three, he apportioned this whole once more into as many parts as was fitting, each part being a mixture of same, other and being.

35b

Timaeus: He began to divide it as follows. First, he separated one part from the entire; after this he separated a part double the first; and next a third, which was one-and-a-half times the second and three times the first; a fourth part, double the second; a fifth, three times the third; a sixth, eight times the first; and a seventh, twenty-seven times the first. After this, he

filled up the double and triple intervals, cutting off further sections of the mixture and placing these in between them, so that in each interval there were two means – one exceeding its extremes and being exceeded by them by the same portion, the other exceeding one extreme and being exceeded by the other extreme by an equal number.¹¹ These connections gave rise to intervals of $3/2$, $4/3$ and $9/8$ between the previous intervals. All the $4/3$ intervals were filled up by the $9/8$ intervals, leaving a portion of each of them, and the interval associated with this remaining portion had the numerical relation $256/243$. What's more, the mixture from which these were cut was at that stage entirely used up in the process.

36c

Timaeus: He then cut this entire compound along its length into two, and situated the middles of each together like the letter χ (chi), bent each into a circle and attached each to itself and to the other one at the point opposite to where they overlap, included them in that kind of motion which turns around uniformly in the same place, and made one of the circles inner and the other outer. The outer movement he designated as the movement of same, the inner as the movement of other. He set the movement of same revolving sideways and to the right, and that of other diagonally and to the left, and he granted supremacy to the movement of same and similar, for he left it one and undivided. However, he divided the inner circle six times, producing seven circles based on the double and triple intervals, there being three of each. He commanded the circles to go in opposite directions to one another, three at similar speeds, four at speeds dissimilar to one another and to the other three, but their movements were proportional.

36d

Timaeus: When the entire construction of the soul had been completed in accordance with the reasoning of the one who constructed it, he then fashioned within it all that has bodily

form, and having brought both together, he fastened them centre to centre. And soul, being woven entirely throughout the Heaven from centre to extremity, enfolding it in a complete circle on the outside and revolving in itself, initiated a divine beginning of unceasing and intelligent life for all time. Now, while the body of the Heaven had come into existence and was visible, soul, for its part, was invisible, partaking of reason and harmony, the best of created things created by the very best of all that is eternal and known by nous.

37a

Timaeus: Now, since soul is blended from these three components (the natures of same, other and being), is divided and combined proportionally, and circles back upon itself, then whenever it touches upon something whose being is scattered, or something whose being is undivided, it is moved throughout its entire self, proclaims what precisely that is the same as, and what it is different from, and also the sense, manner and occasion that each is so and is characterised as such, either in relation to things that come to be, or in relation to the unchanging and eternal. And the account which arises, being equally true, whether it concerns that which is other or same, is borne along without utterance or sound in that which is moved by itself. Whenever it arises concerning perceptible things, and the circle of other, running true, announces it through the entire soul, opinions and beliefs arise which are certain and true. But whenever, in contrast, it arises concerning the things of reason, and the circuit of same, running well, makes these things known, nous and knowledge are the necessary outcome. If anyone should ever say that these two arise in anything other than soul, he will be speaking entirely contrary to the truth.

37c

Timaeus: When the father who brought it into being realised it was moving and living, a delight created for the everlasting gods, he too was delighted, and in his rejoicing he decided to

make it even more like its model. Now, since the model is an everlasting, living creature, he also undertook, accordingly, to render this Universe as much like that as possible. Now, in fact, the nature of the living creature was everlasting, and it was not actually possible to completely impart eternity to the created entity, so he decided to make a moving image, and as he ordered the Heaven, he made an everlasting image of eternity abiding in unity, moving according to number, an image we have called time, for there were no days or nights, months or years, before the Heaven came to be. Then, at the same time as the Heaven was constructed, he arranged the creation of these. All of these are but parts of time and 'was' and 'will be' are forms of time which have been generated, although we do not notice this and apply these incorrectly to everlasting being. We do indeed say 'was', 'is' and 'will be', when 'is' alone is appropriate to it according to the true account, while it is more fitting to say 'was' and 'will be' of generation which unfolds in time, for both of these are movements. It does not belong to what is always the same and unmoving to become older or younger in the course of time, nor to have ever come into being, nor to have come into being now, nor to be about to exist in future. And, in general, nothing that generation attaches to motions in the sensory realm belongs to it, for these have come into being, forms of time, time which imitates eternity and revolves according to number. What's more, we even say such things as, "what has come to be 'is' what has come to be", and "what is coming to be 'is' coming to be", and again, "what will come to be 'is' what will come to be", and "what is not 'is' what is not", but none of these statements are accurate. Perhaps, though, it is not the right time now for a precise discussion of these issues.

38b

Timaeus: In any case, time came into being along with the heavens, so that having been generated simultaneously they

would also be dissolved simultaneously, if they were ever dissolved, and it was based on the model of the eternal nature so that it would be as much like it as possible. For, indeed, the model is through all eternity, while the Heaven, for its part, having come into being, is, and will be, throughout all time.

38c

Timaeus: Based on such reasoning and consideration of the god about the creation of time, in order that time might come into being, the Sun, Moon and five other stars, which are called wanderers,¹² were generated to define and protect the numbers of time. Having made the bodies of each of these, the god placed them in the orbits in which the circuit of other was moving – seven bodies in seven orbits. The Moon he placed in the first orbit around the Earth, the Sun in the second above the Earth, the Morning Star too,¹³ and the one said to be sacred to Hermes¹⁴ he set moving in circles at an equal speed to the Sun, but allotted a power opposite to it so that Sun, Mercury and Venus alike overtake and are overtaken by one another. As for the other planets, if someone were to recount everything about them and the reasons he established them, the story, though a subsidiary one, would prove to be a greater task than our main undertaking. Indeed, all this may perhaps get proper attention later, at our leisure.

38e

Timaeus: In any case, when each had occupied its own proper course as needed to help in the production of time, these bodies were bound with bonds of soul and became living creatures and learned their assigned duties, each moving in actual accord with the sideways motion of the circuit of other, which revolves within the circuit of same and is ruled by it, some traversing a greater circle, some a lesser, those in the lesser circle revolving faster, those in the greater revolving more slowly. Due to the motion of same, those which went around fastest seemed to be overtaken by the slowest, though they actually overtook the

slowest. For the movement of same, which is the swiftest of all motions, turned all their circles in a spiral due to their divided, and also opposite, forward motion, and it made that which moves away from itself most slowly seem closest to it in speed.

39b

Timaeus: So that there might be some obvious measure of their relative slowness or swiftness, and so that the eight courses might proceed, the god kindled a light in the second of the orbits from the Earth, a light we now call the Sun, so that it would shine with all its might through the entire Heaven, and all deserving creatures would have a share in number, having learned it from the revolutions of same and similar. So this is how and these are the reasons why day and night, the revolution of the single most intelligent circuit, have come into being. However, when the Moon traverses its own circuit and overtakes the Sun, a month is generated, and whenever the Sun completes its own circuit, a year is generated. Men, save a few of them, have not understood the periods of the other planets, nor have they named them, nor have they measured them against one another through numerical investigation. Consequently, they do not really understand that the numerous, complex and wonderfully intricate wanderings of these planets actually constitute time. Yet it is possible, nevertheless, to understand that the perfect number of time fulfils the perfect year, when the speeds with respect to one another belonging to all eight orbits are concluded simultaneously and they have attained completion as measured by the circuit of same, and similarly moving. So, based on these principles and for these reasons, the stars came into being, those which have their turnings and proceed through Heaven, so that this Universe might be as much like the perfect, intelligible creature as possible in its imitation of the eternal nature.

39e

Timaeus: Now, in other respects, including the creation of time, the Universe was already fashioned very like the model it was imitating. However, it was still unlike it in one respect, as it did not yet contain, generated within itself, all the living creatures. He set about this remaining task by moulding the Universe towards the nature of the model. In the same way that nous beholds how many and what kind of forms are contained in that actual living being, he decided that this Universe too should possess such kinds as these, in such numbers. Now, there are four kinds, one the heavenly race of gods, another winged and airborne, a third type dwelling in water, and a fourth traversing dry land on foot.

40a

Timaeus: The form of the divine race he made mostly from fire so that it would be the brightest and most beautiful to behold, and to make it resemble the Universe, he made it well rounded. He placed it in the intelligence of the dominant circuit to follow that path, and distributed it around the entire Heaven in a circle, to be a true adornment to it, embroidered over the whole. He assigned two movements to each, one an unchanging movement in the same place, always thinking to itself the same thoughts about the same things, the other a forward motion dominated by the revolutions of same and similar.¹⁵ They are devoid of the other five motions and are at rest, so that each of them may become as excellent as possible.¹⁶ From this cause, all the un-wandering stars have come into being – divine, everlasting creatures which abide forever, revolving in the same way in the same place. But those that turn back and keep wandering in this fashion have come into being in the manner we described before. And Earth, our nurse, packed about the axis stretching through the Universe, he devised as guardian and artificer of night and day, the first and eldest of all the gods that have come into existence within the Heaven.

40c

Timaeus: As for the dances of the gods themselves and their juxtapositions with one another, the backward revolutions of the circuits upon themselves and their advances which are in line with each other during conjunctions, and how many are behind and what each is hidden by, both from themselves and from us so that when they reappear they send terrors and portents of things to come to men who are not capable of reasoning..., to describe this without a visible model of the movements would be a vain task. Rather, we should be satisfied at that and let our discussions about the nature of the visible and generated gods come to an end.

40d

Timaeus: To describe and understand the origin of the other divinities is beyond us, so we must believe those who have already spoken and who claim to be the offspring of the gods, and presumably know their own ancestors very well. Now, it is impossible to disbelieve the children of gods even though they speak without any probable or compelling evidence; yet they speak as though they are describing family matters, so we should follow custom and believe them. Accordingly, let us accept their version of the generation of those gods and let us describe it. Ocean and Tethys were born children of Earth and Heaven, and from these were born Phorcys, Cronus and Rhea, and all their companions. From Cronus and Rhea came Zeus, Hera, and all those we know by report as their brothers and sisters, and a further generation born from these.

41a

Timaeus: In any case, when all the gods had come into being, both those who wander about conspicuously and the ones who appear only as often as they wish, he who had generated this Universe spoke to them and said, "Gods of gods, works of which I am the maker and father, what I have brought into being is indissoluble unless I so desire. Now, anything that is bound together can indeed be dissolved, but only bad would wish to

dissolve something which has been beautifully harmonised and is in good order. Since you have come into being, you are not truly immortal or entirely indissoluble, and yet there is nothing which will dissolve you, nor will the fate of death befall you, because in my will you have an even greater and more powerful bond granted you than those by which you were bound together at birth. Therefore, understand the declaration I am now making to you. There are three types of mortal creatures yet to be created. If these are not brought into existence, the Heaven will be incomplete for it will not have within itself all types of creatures, and it must have these if it is to be complete in an adequate manner. But if they were brought into being and partook of life through my agency, they would be equal unto gods. Therefore, so that they may be mortal and this Universe truly universal, betake yourselves, as is natural to you, to the production of living creatures, imitating the power by which I brought you into being.

41d

Timaeus: "Now, I shall begin by sowing the seed and handing over to you the part of the creatures which rightly shares the same name as the immortals, the part which is called divine and which rules supreme in those who desire always to follow justice and yourselves. You must do the rest – make the living creatures by weaving the immortal with the mortal, give them birth, nourish them and make them grow, and when they perish, receive them back again."

Timaeus: The maker of the Universe said this and went again to the mixing bowl in which he had previously mixed and blended the soul of the Universe. He poured in the remainder of the former mixture, blending it in somewhat the same manner, but it was no longer pure in the same way as before, but second or third in degree of purity. When he had compounded the entire, he divided it into souls equal in number with the stars, allocated

each soul to its particular star, and, having mounted them as though in a chariot, he showed them the nature of the Universe and told them the laws of destiny: that the first birth would be arranged the same for everyone so that no one would be disadvantaged at his hands; that they should be dispersed to the instruments of time appropriate to each to grow as the most god-revering of creatures; and the nature of humanity being twofold, the stronger would be the kind which should hereafter be called man. Once the souls were, of necessity, implanted in bodies, and there was a process of addition and removal of portions of their bodies, in the first place an innate sense perception would necessarily arise in all, produced from forceful impressions; second would be love mixed with pleasure and pain, and, in addition to these, fear and desire and all that follows in their train, and whatever stands in natural opposition to these. If they should conquer these they would live justly, but if conquered by them, unjustly. Whoever lived well during his assigned period of life would journey again to his native home, which is his kindred star, to live a happy life in conformity with his nature. But if he should fall short of this, he would transform into a woman's nature in his second birth. And if in this form he still does not desist from wrongdoing, as is the manner of his corruption so also is his transformation into an animal nature that resembles his evil tendency. He will not cease from these painful transformations until he draws into the circuit of same and similar that is within himself, the vast accretion composed of fire and water, earth and air, which has grown about him of late, has conquered its turbulence and irrationality by reason, and returns again to the form of his original and most excellent condition.

42d

Timaeus: When he had prescribed all these laws for humans so that he would be blameless of their future evil doings, he sowed some of them in the Earth, some in the Moon, and some in the

other instruments of time. But when the sowing was complete, he handed over the making of mortal bodies to the young gods, and, as well as that, the fashioning of all the parts of human souls that still had to be added, and all that goes along with them. And they were also to govern this mortal creature and guide it as beautifully and excellently as they could, unless it should become a source of evil to itself.

42e

Timaeus: He who had decreed all this remained as usual in his own accustomed state, and as he so remained, the children understood the direction of their father and obeyed it. They took from him the immortal beginning of the mortal creature, and imitating their own artificer, they borrowed portions of fire, earth, water and air from the Universe, intending to return these again. What they had taken they bonded together into a unity, not with the indissoluble bonds with which they themselves had been conjoined, but fusing them together with myriad tiny invisible pegs. Fashioning each body as a unity from all the elements, they bound the circuits of the immortal soul within the inflowing and out-flowing body. These orbits, which were bound within an enormous stream, neither dominated it nor were dominated by it, but they brought about and suffered violent motion. So the entire creature was moved, and it advanced, randomly and irrationally, in any way at all, exhibiting all six types of movement at once as it progressed forward and backward, and then right and left, down and up, as it went wandering in all six directions. The surge which poured in and gushed out and brought nutriment was mighty indeed, but greater yet was the disturbance to each wrought by all the impinging sensations when the body happened to collide with fire from something external and alien, or with a hard lump of earth or smooth sliding waters, or was carried away by a storm of winds borne by the air. And the movements caused by all these, being borne through the body, fell upon the soul. Indeed,

on account of all this, such movements were called sensations thereafter and are still so called today.¹⁷ Furthermore, at that particular time these were the source of the greatest and most varied movement, and along with the constantly flowing stream they moved and shook the revolutions of the soul violently, completely blocked the revolution of same by flowing against it, and prevented it from ruling and proceeding. And what's more, they threw the revolution of other into confusion, turning each of the three double and triple intervals and the $3/2$, $4/3$ and $9/8$ middle terms and connections in all directions, and although they could not be entirely undone save by their maker, they caused all manner of fractures and deformations of the circles so that they moved along, but barely holding themselves together, borne irrationally, sometimes in opposite directions, sometimes sideways, sometimes upside down.

43e

Timaeus: Just as whenever someone is propped upside down, his head on the ground, his feet pressed against something, in that predicament what is right for the person will appear as left to his observers, and what is left for him will appear right for them. So when the circuits are undergoing this experience, and others like this, in an intense manner, whenever they happen upon something external of the class of same or of other, they then declare it to be same as something or other than something, in direct opposition to the truth, having become false and devoid of intelligence, without even one orbit ruling and leading among them at that time. Indeed, should some sense impressions, carried from outside to the orbits of the soul and impinging on them, draw the entire vessel of the soul along with them, then although the orbits seem to be dominating themselves, they are being dominated by the senses. And, indeed, because of all these experiences, the soul now, as in the beginning, becomes devoid of nous at first whenever it is bound within a mortal body. But whenever the stream which brings

growth and nourishment lessens its influx, and the orbits become calm again, traverse their own paths and become more stable with the passing of time, then at that stage the orbits are kept in line with the course of the natural motion of each of the circles, they proclaim other and same correctly, and cause their possessor to become intelligent. And, indeed, if some right nurture should also play a role in his education, he becomes completely unblemished and sound, having escaped the worst possible disease. However, if he neglects this, he limps his way through life and returns once more to Hades, incomplete and devoid of intelligence.

44c

Timaeus: Of course, this all happens later on. However, we must deal more precisely with the issues before us now, and issues prior to these concerning the generation of the body part by part, and of the soul too, and the reasons and intentions of the gods in producing them. This we must recount in detail, holding to the most likely account and proceeding on that basis.

44d

Timaeus: Now, there are two divine revolutions which imitate the round shape of the Universe, which is spherical, and they bound these within a spherically shaped body which we now call the head. It is our most divine part, and it rules over all else within us, and to this the gods granted the entire body which they had assembled to be its servant, realising that it would be involved in every kind of motion that would ever be. They gave this chariot and means of transport to the head so that it would not go rolling about the Earth with its various hills and hollows, unable to get over the one or out of the other. On account of this, the body is tall and has grown four flexible and extensible limbs devised by the god for conveyance. Assisted and supported by these, the body is capable of traversing all terrains, bearing aloft the dwelling place of that most divine and sacred part of us. So that is how and why legs and feet have

been attached to everyone. And regarding the front of the body as nobler and more fitted for leadership than the rear, the gods assigned most of our movement to be in that direction. So it was necessary for the front of the human body to be distinct and different. Therefore, they first put the face in position on that particular side of the vessel of the head, affixed onto it the organs for complete providence of the soul, and assigned the role of leadership to that natural front.

45b

Timaeus: The first of the organs fabricated were light-bearing eyes which they fixed in place for the following reason: they contrived to create a body from fire which does not burn but provides a gentle light, kindred to the light of each day. So they caused the pure fire within us, which is brother of this light of day, to flow through the eyes, and they compressed the whole eye, but especially the centre, to be smooth and dense so as to retain all the coarser fire and filter through only this kind of pure fire by itself. Then, if ever there is daylight surrounding this stream of vision, like meets with like, joins together and establishes a single kindred body along a straight line from the eyes to wherever the stream from within is obstructed by the outside objects on which it impinges.

45c

Timaeus: Because the entire body is similar, the effects are similar throughout. So once this body of light touches something or is touched by something, it transmits motions from these through the entire body as far as the soul and furnishes perception, and we call this 'seeing'. But when the kindred fire goes away at night, the stream of vision is cut off, for when it travels out into something dissimilar it is altered and extinguished, no longer merging with the adjacent air since it contains no fire. So it stops seeing, and, what's more, it becomes an inducement to sleep. For the eyelids, devised by the gods as the natural protector of vision, confine the power of

that fire within whenever these are closed. This dissolves and equalises the inner movements, and once these are calmed, peace arises, and when there is great peace there falls an almost dreamless sleep. However, if any significant movements of any sort remain in any location, they produce images which are like these movements in type and quantity, images which are copied within and are remembered externally upon awakening.

46a

Timaeus: Now, there is no particular difficulty in understanding the production of images in mirrors or anything smooth and reflective. For all such images necessarily make their appearance from the communion of the inner and outer fire with one another, and then, whenever this in turn unites on the smooth surface and is transformed in different ways, and the fire from the reflected face coalesces with the fire of sight on the smooth and bright surface, left then appears to be right because opposite parts of the beam of sight make contact with the corresponding parts in a manner contrary to the normal manner of contact. However, right appears as right and left as left whenever light changes side in the process of merging. This happens when the smooth surface of the mirrors is raised on each side, and the right part of the beam of sight is repelled to the left and the left to the right. When the same mirror is turned lengthwise to the face, it makes all appear upside down by repelling the bottom of the beam to the top, and the top to the bottom.

46c

Timaeus: Now, all these are contributory causes which the god employs as servants in perfecting the most excellent form that is possible. But they are regarded by most people not as contributory causes, but as the cause of everything – cooling and heating, solidifying and melting, and all such processes. Yet these are unable to think or reason to any end. For we must declare that among things that are, it belongs to soul alone to

acquire nous, and this is invisible, while fire, water, earth and air are all visible bodies. And the lover of nous and knowledge first needs to investigate the causes which belong to the intelligent nature, and secondly, those causes which are moved by others, and of necessity become a source of motion to other objects. We too should act in accordance with these principles. We must, indeed, describe both types of causes, yet distinguish those which, in consort with nous, are artificers of beauty and good from those which, being bereft of intelligence, consistently bring about randomness and disorder.

46e

Timaeus: Let that be enough about the ancillary, contributory causes for which the eyes have been assigned the power they now possess. However, along with this we must also state the greatest of their beneficial effects, the reason the god gave them to us. According to my account, sight is responsible for the greatest benefit to us, because not one of the accounts we are relating about the Universe would ever have been spoken without seeing the stars or the Sun or the Heaven. But now that day and night have been seen, months and the annual cycle too, and equinoxes and solstices, number has been devised, and the concept of time and the investigation of the nature of the Universe have been given to us. From this we have acquired philosophy in general, and no greater good has ever or will ever come to mortal creatures as a gift from the gods than this. So I declare this to be the greatest good of eyes. As for the other lesser sights, why should we praise benefits for which someone who is no philosopher, weeping in vain,¹⁸ might lament if he lost the sight of them? Rather, let us declare for the following reasons that sight is the cause of this benefit. Sight was invented and bestowed upon us by the god so that we, beholding the revolutions of nous in the Heaven, could apply them to the orbits of thinking within ourselves, for these, though troubled, are kindred to those untroubled revolutions.

And, indeed, by learning these thoroughly and properly in accord with their nature, we could stabilise the wandering motions within ourselves by imitating the entirely stable orbits of the god. And in the case of sound and of hearing, the account is the same; they were bestowed by the gods for the same reasons and with the same intentions as they gave sight. Indeed, speech too was instituted for these very purposes, and it contributes the greatest portion thereto, and so too does any music which works through sound and hearing, and is given for the sake of harmony. Harmony, whose movements are kindred to the orbits in our own soul, has been given by the Muses to those who resort to them intelligently, not for the irrational pleasure thought to be so useful nowadays, but as an ally against the inharmonious orbit of the soul which has arisen in us, to bring it to order and concord with itself. Rhythm, too, was given to us for the same reasons, by the same gods, as an aid, because of the unmeasured condition and lack of grace which, for the most part, prevails in us.

47e

Timaeus: Now, everything we have said so far, with few exceptions, has expounded the productions of nous.¹⁹ However, we must also set alongside it an account of what comes into being through Necessity. For the generation of this Universe originated indeed in a mixture produced from the combination of Necessity and nous. Nous ruled over Necessity by persuading it to lead most of what comes into being towards the very best. And so, this Universe was constructed in this way and on these principles in the beginning, through the subjugation of Necessity by intelligent persuasion. Therefore, if anyone is to state truly how the Universe came into being, based on these principles, he must include also the form of the wandering cause and how it is naturally involved. So, we should retrace our steps once more, and, adopting a different and appropriate fresh starting point from these themselves, we must now begin

again from the beginning, based on these factors just as we did before.

48b

Timaeus: We should look to the nature itself of fire and water, and also air and earth, before the generation of the Heaven and the condition they were in prior to that. For, to this day, no one has yet disclosed their origin, but we speak as if we know what precisely fire and each of the others is – proposing that they are the principles and letters of the Universe – when to a man of even a little intelligence it is probably not appropriate even to liken them to syllables. So let our statement on the matter be as follows: we should not speak now of the beginning of all things, or the beginnings, or the way we think about them, for no other reason than the difficulty of presenting our opinions based upon the present manner of exposition. Nor should you believe that I need to address this topic, nor would I, for my part, be able to persuade myself that I would be right in attempting to burden myself with such a task. So, paying special heed to our initial statement about the capability of the likely accounts, I shall endeavour to give an account no less likely than before – indeed, more so – from the beginning about each and everything.

48e

Timaeus: Clearly we should now begin again, once we have called upon the god, our saviour, at the very outset of our deliberations, to see us safely out of an unusual and unaccustomed exposition to the doctrine of things probable. In any case, our fresh start concerning the Universe should be more elaborate than before, for we distinguished two forms then, but now we must present a third kind. Two were sufficient for our previous descriptions, one designated as a sort of a model discernible by nous and ever the same, while the second was a copy of the model, involved in becoming, and visible. We did not distinguish a third kind at the time as we thought it

enough to have these two, but now the argument seems to compel us to try to manifest a difficult and obscure form in words. What should we understand its power and nature to be? This in particular – it is the receptacle of all coming into being, like its nurse.

49a

Timaeus: Now, although the truth has been spoken, a clearer statement about it is still required, but it is difficult to do so, particularly because it is necessary for the sake of this to raise a preliminary problem about fire and its accompaniments. It is difficult in the case of each of these to state what sort should actually be called water rather than fire, and what sort should be referred to as anything in particular rather than as everything individually, in such a manner as to employ language which is trustworthy and certain. How, then, may we speak about them in a likely manner, and in what way, and what can we say about them when faced with this problem? First, we see what we now call water being condensed and becoming stones and earth, or so we think, and when melted or dispersed, the same substance in turn becomes wind and air, and air when burned becomes fire. When this is combined once more and the fire is extinguished, it returns again to the form of air, and air comes together again, becomes dense and forms cloud and mist, and by compacting these even more we get flowing water, and from water we go on to get earth and stones. And their coming into being appears to be a cycle where they interchange with one another in this way.

49d

Timaeus: Accordingly, since none of these ever appears the same, which of them can a person firmly assert to be 'this something or other' and not something else, without embarrassing himself? It is not possible, and by far the most cautious approach when making assertions about these is to speak as follows: whatever we observe continually becoming in

different ways at different times – fire, for instance – we should consistently refer to²⁰ not as 'this' but as 'like this'; and we should not refer to water as 'this' but always as 'such as this'; nor ever refer to anything else as something possessing fixity by using the terms 'this' and 'that' and presume that we are pointing to anything. For they take flight and do not wait for the 'this' and the 'that' and the 'thereby', and whatever expressions indicate that they are constant. So we should not use these terms about them, but in relation to each of them, and all of them together, we should describe them as 'such as this, ever recurring alike'. And, indeed, we should call fire that which is such as this throughout, and so for all things that involve coming into being. But we should refer only to that in which each of these makes its appearance and into which each dissolves again thereafter, by using the terms 'this' and 'that'. However, anything with some sort of quality, be it hot or white, or any of the opposites, or anything derived from these, should be referred to by none of these terms.

50a

Timaeus: But I must make an effort to explain this anew even more clearly. Indeed, if someone, having moulded all manner of shapes out of gold, were to keep on remoulding each shape into all the others without stopping, and someone were to point to one of them and ask what it is in truth, the safest answer is gold. But the triangle, and all the other shapes arising in it, we should never refer to as 'these' as if they were things that are, for they change even as we make the assertion. Rather, we should be content if they deign to accept the cautious designation 'such as this'. Then we must also give the same account of the nature of the recipient of all these bodies; we must assert that it is always the same, since it never departs at all from its own capacity. For it is always receiving everything, but it never adopts a shape similar to the things which enter into it in any way at all. There it lies, the natural recipient of all impressions, moved and

shaped by the things that enter it, seeming to change from time to time because of these. What enters it and leaves it are imitations of the things that are always, modelled upon them in some manner which is hard to describe and extraordinary, which we shall deal with on another occasion.

50c

Timaeus: Leaving that aside, we must now conceive of three kinds: that which comes into being; that in which it comes into being; and the original, in the likeness of which that which comes into being grows. What's more, it is appropriate to liken the recipient to a mother, the original to a father, and the nature arising between these to an offspring. And we must also understand that if the recipient of impressions is to display all the varieties of embellishment, this entity in which the impressions will be set would need to be well prepared, and this will not occur unless it is devoid of all of those characteristics which it is about to receive from elsewhere. For if it were similar to anything that entered it, then whenever something of an opposite or completely different nature entered and was received, the receptacle would present a bad likeness as its own feature would intrude. Therefore, that which receives all forms into itself must also be devoid of all qualities, just as skilled perfumers contrive firstly to do just this, making the oil which will receive the scents as odourless as possible. And whoever turns his hand to moulding shapes in some soft material allows no shape at all to be present beforehand, but they even it out first, and render it as smooth as possible. In the same way, it is fitting that whatever will continually, throughout its entire self, receive the likenesses of all that is known by nous, and is always, should also be naturally devoid of all forms. So, then, the mother and receptacle of what is generated, visible and in every respect perceptible, should not be called earth or air or fire or water, or anything that they produce or that from which they arise. Yet, we shall not deceive ourselves if we say it is an

invisible and shapeless form, all-receiving, participating in a most baffling way in that which can be known by nous, and hard to understand. Insofar as it is possible to arrive at its nature from our previous deliberations, it would be most correct to describe it as follows: the part that has become fiery appears at the same time as fire, the moistened part as water, and as earth and air also, to the extent that it receives imitations of these.

51b

Timaeus: And yet, we must investigate this further through argument by making distinctions about these. Is there such a thing as fire just by itself, and everything that we constantly refer to in this way, each as things in themselves? Or is it only what we look at, and anything else we perceive through the body, that possesses this sort of truth, and is there nothing else besides these in any sense whatsoever? And do we speak idly every time we declare that there is a form of each, discernible by nous? Is this, in the end, nothing but a word? Now, it would be appropriate neither to dismiss the present issue by asserting that this is how matters stand without any deliberation or judgement, nor should we insert another lengthy, secondary topic into an already lengthy discourse. Yet, if it proved possible to make a significant distinction quite briefly, that would be most appropriate to our purpose. So, I cast my own vote as follows: if nous and true opinion indeed represent two kinds, then, definitively, there are these forms, just by themselves, incapable of being perceived by our senses, known by nous alone. However, if, as it appears to some, true opinion does not differ at all from nous, then by contrast, everything that we perceive by means of the body must be designated as most certain. Well, we must declare that these are two, because they have arisen independently and have dissimilar characteristics. One of them is engendered through instruction, the other through persuasion; one always arises along with a true

account, while the other is devoid of an account; and one is unmoved by persuasion, while the other is amenable to persuasion. Indeed, all men may be said to partake of opinion, but only the gods and some small class of humanity partake of nous.

52a

Timaeus: Since this is how matters stand, we must agree that the form which is always the same is one, ungenerated, undecaying, neither receiving anything into itself from anywhere else, nor entering into anything else anywhere, invisible and imperceptible. Nous has been assigned the task of investigating this. The second bears the same name as that and is similar thereto – perceptible, generated, constantly being moved, coming into being in some location, then perishing out of that place once more. It is apprehended by opinion accompanied by sense perception. The third kind is space, which is always, not accepting destruction, providing a basis for everything that comes into being, itself apprehended without involving the senses by some spurious reasoning difficult to believe in. This, indeed, we look towards and we engage in dreams, declaring that whatever is must presumably be in some location and occupy some space, and whatever is not, somehow either on Earth or in Heaven, is nothing. On account of this dreaming, we become unable, on awakening, to make these distinctions and others akin to them, even in relation to the unsleeping and truly subsisting nature, and to state the truth that in the case of an image, since it does not itself even possess the very thing it has been fashioned after, but always bears an appearance belonging to something else, it is appropriate for these reasons that it come into being in something different, clinging onto being in some way or other lest it be absolutely nothing. However, in support of what actually is, the precise and true account states that as long as one thing is different from another, neither can ever come into being in the other so

that they simultaneously become one and the same, and two.

52d

Timaeus: So let this concisely argued account be the one that receives my vote. There is being, space and becoming, these three, even before the Heaven comes into being. And yet the nurse of becoming, rendered watery and fiery, and receiving the forms of earth and air and adopting whatever other characteristics are a consequence of these, presents a variegated appearance. And because of being filled with powers that are neither similar nor equally balanced, no part of it is equally balanced. Rather, being swayed irregularly in all directions, it is shaken by those powers, and, as it moves, it in turn shakes them once more. And as they move, borne continually in one direction or another, they are separated, just like materials shaken and sifted by sieves and instruments for purifying grain; the dense and heavy components go one way, while the loose and light components are carried to a different place and settle there. The four kinds were then shaken in this way by the receptacle, itself moving like an instrument for shaking, separating the most dissimilar as far apart as possible from one another, while forcing the most similar together into the same place. And so it was that these different kinds each occupied a distinct space, even before the Universe organised from them had come into being. Indeed, prior to this they all behaved in an irrational and unmeasured manner. However, when the Universe was brought to order, fire, water, earth and air did possess some traces of themselves, and yet they were entirely in the sort of state that anything is likely to be in when god is absent from it. Such being their nature at the time, the god first gave them a structure by means of forms and numbers. Let this, above all, be our constant assertion: the god constructed them to be as beautiful and excellent as possible, but this was not their previous condition. But now I must attempt to show you the structure of each of them, and their

origin, by means of an unfamiliar account. And yet, since you have been involved in the courses of education that I must draw upon to demonstrate my assertion, you will follow me.

53c

Timaeus: Now, in the first place, fire and earth, water and air are bodies, as is obvious to everyone I presume, and the form of every body also possesses depth. And it is absolutely necessary that depth, in turn, be contained by a flat surface, and any straight-sided flat surface is constructed from triangles. All triangles originate from two triangles, each of which possesses a single right angle while the others are acute. One of them has half a right angle on either side, divided by equal sides, while in the other case the portions of the right angle are unequal, apportioned by unequal sides.²¹ So, proceeding on the basis of the likely account, accompanied by necessity, we propose this as the origin of fire and the other bodies, but any origins still higher than these god knows, and so do any men who are dear to him. So we need to state what the most beautiful bodies would be, four in number, dissimilar to one another, and yet capable of arising from one another in some cases when they are broken apart. For once we accomplish this, we are in possession of the truth concerning the generation of earth and fire and whatever lies between them in a proportion. Indeed, we shall not concede to anyone that there are visible bodies more beautiful than these anywhere, each based upon a single kind.

54a

Timaeus: So we must be eager to construct the four types of bodies that excel in beauty, and to declare that we have sufficiently understood their nature. In the case of the pair of triangles, there is only one type of isosceles triangle but an unlimited number of scalenes. Therefore, we must proceed to select the most beautiful from this unlimited number if we intend to begin methodically. Yet if anyone can declare that he has chosen something more beautiful for the construction of

these bodies, he will be victorious, not as an enemy but as a friend. And so, passing over the others, we propose one of the numerous triangles as the most beautiful, the one from which the equilateral triangle is constructed as a third. The explanation for this is a longer story, but if anyone refutes this and discovers that it is not the case, the prize is his, as a friend.

54b

Timaeus: So we shall select two triangles from which the bodies of fire and of the others have been devised. One is the isosceles, while the other has a long side that is always triple the short side when they are squared. However, something stated earlier in an imprecise manner should now be made more definite, for when it appeared that the four kinds all underwent generation from one another and into one another, the appearances were incorrect. The four kinds do indeed arise from the triangles we selected, and while three are constructed from the one that has unequal sides, the fourth one alone is constructed from the isosceles. So it is not possible for them all to be generated from one another when they are broken apart so that a few large kinds are produced from numerous smaller kinds and vice versa. Only three of them can do this because they arise naturally from a single triangle, and, by breaking up the larger bodies, numerous smaller bodies can be formed from the same triangles as the bodies take on the shapes appropriate to themselves. Then again, the small bodies, when dispersed into their constituent triangles, would give rise to another large single form once they constitute a single number belonging to a single volume.

54d

Timaeus: Now, that is enough said about their generation from one another. Next, we should explain what the form of each of them is like and the numbers that come together to constitute it. Now, we begin with the construction of the first and smallest form. Its element of composition is the triangle having its

hypotenuse double the shortest side in length. If a pair of such triangles is placed along a diagonal, and this is done three times, with the diagonals and the short sides fixed to the same point as though it were a centre, then from these, six in number, a single equilateral triangle is produced. And when four equilateral triangles are combined based on three flat angles coming together, a single solid angle is produced, the one that comes next after the most obtuse of flat angles.²² And when four such solid angles have been completed, the first solid form that apportions the entire surface of a sphere into equal and similar parts is constructed.²³

54e

Timaeus: The second is composed of the same triangles but arranged into eight equilateral triangles which produce a single solid angle from four flat angles, and when six solid angles like this have been generated, the second solid form is, in turn, brought to completion. The third is composed of one hundred and twenty of the elemental triangles combined together. It has twelve solid angles, each bounded by five flat equilateral triangles, and twenty faces consisting of equilateral triangles. Now, this elemental triangle was released from duty once it had produced these three forms, and the isosceles triangle then produced the fourth kind when it was assembled in groups of four, with their right angles joining at the centre to form a single equilateral quadrangle.²⁴ And six such surfaces when brought together produced eight solid angles, each consisting of three flat right angles, and the shape of the assembled body was the cube with its six flat equilateral quadrangular faces. One construction still remained, the fifth, and God used this in order to embroider shapes upon the Universe.²⁵

55c

Timaeus: Now, suppose someone considering all this with due measure were to become perplexed over whether we should say there are an unlimited number of universes or that there is

some limit. He would regard the opinion that the number is unlimited as belonging to someone who is actually inexperienced on issues about which he should be experienced, but, on the other hand, the question of whether it is in truth ever appropriate to say that there is naturally one universe or five, if he were to stop there, would provide more reasonable grounds for perplexity. Now, our approach, based upon the likely account, reveals that it is by nature a single god, but someone else, in view of some other considerations, may form different opinions.

55d

Timaeus: Now, we should dismiss this fellow and allocate the four types that have been generated to fire, earth, water and air. So let's assign the cubic form to earth, since earth is the most immobile of the four types and it is the most malleable of bodies, so it is especially necessary that this be the sort that has the most stable bases. And of the two triangles we proposed at the outset, a base made from the one with equal sides is naturally more stable than a base made from the one with unequal sides; and in the case of the equal-sided surfaces constructed from either triangle, the square is necessarily more resistant to motion than the equilateral triangle, both as a whole and according to its parts. Therefore, we shall preserve the likely account by assigning this form to earth, and of those that remain the hardest to move is assigned to water, the easiest to move to fire, and the intermediate kind to air. Again, the smallest body is assigned to fire, the largest to water, and the intermediate to air; and the sharpest again to fire, the second sharpest to air, and the third sharpest to water. Now, in all these cases, the one that has the fewest bases is necessarily the most mobile by nature, since it is the most incisive and the sharpest of them all in every respect, and also the lightest since it is composed of the fewest identical parts. The second lies in second place based on these same factors, while the third lies in

third place.

56b

Timaeus: So, in accordance with the correct and likely account, let the solid form that constitutes a pyramid be the element and seed of fire, and we may say that the second in order of generation belongs to air, and the third to water. Now, we need to realise that these are all so small that an individual particular of each kind is invisible to us due to its extreme smallness, and yet, when a large number are aggregated together, their bulks are visible. As for the proportions associated with their multiplicity, movements, and their other capacities, insofar as the nature of Necessity allowed under willing persuasion, we must realise that God fitted them together entirely in due proportion once he had precisely perfected them in this comprehensive manner.

56d

Timaeus: Now, from all that we have said earlier about the kinds, they would be most likely to behave as follows. Earth, on encountering fire and being broken apart by its sharpness – regardless of whether it is in fire itself when it gets broken up, or in a mass of air or water – would travel along until such time as it somehow meets up with its own parts, which, once fitted together with themselves, become earth again, for they could never have adopted any other form. Water, when broken apart either by fire or air, is capable of combining to constitute one body of fire and two of air, while the components of air, when a single portion is broken up, would become two bodies of fire. And again, when a little fire is surrounded by a lot of air or water, or even by some earth, and is in motion within them, does battle, gets defeated and is shattered, two bodies of fire combine into a single figure of air. And if air is defeated and broken in pieces, one whole figure of water will be compounded from two and a half of air.

57a

Timaeus: In fact, we may consider them again as follows. Whenever one of the other types is surrounded by fire and is cut by its sharp corners and edges, it stops being cut once it recombines into the nature of fire. For in each case, a kind that is the same and similar is unable to effect any change in or be affected by anything that is the same as itself and has similar characteristics. However, as long as it transforms into something else, as a lesser contesting against a stronger, its dissolution is unceasing. And furthermore, whenever a few smaller units, being surrounded by many that are larger, are broken apart and quenched, then, if they recombine and adopt the form of the dominant units, their quenching ceases and air arises from fire, or water from air. But if, as they are going in this direction, one of the other kinds comes upon them and attacks them, there is no end to their dissolution until they are either completely broken up by the pressure and take flight towards their kindred, or they are overcome, and out of the multiplicity constitute a unit like unto their conqueror and abide thereafter as its neighbour. And, indeed, during these processes they all exchange their locations, for although the vast bulk of each kind is set apart in its own place because of the motion of the receptacle, those that are in the process of becoming unlike themselves, but like others, are borne by the shaking towards the place belonging to the kinds they are becoming like.

57c

Timaeus: Now, it is through such causes as these that the unmixed and primary bodies have arisen, and yet the different types that exist within the forms of these four must be attributed to the construction of the two elementals. This initially produced a triangle in each case that was not of one size only; rather, some were smaller, some larger, and the number of different sizes corresponded to the number of different types among the four kinds. And so, as they combine

with themselves and one another, their diversity is unlimited, a diversity that must be contemplated by anyone who intends to have recourse to the likely account in relation to natural phenomena.

57d

Timaeus: Now, if there is not some agreement on the origin of motion and rest and the manner in which they arise, our subsequent reasoning would be much impeded. And although something has been said about them already, the following should still be added. Where there is uniformity, motion is never inclined to arise. For it is difficult, impossible really, that there be something moved without that which moves it, or for something to be a mover without something that is moved. In the absence of these there is no movement, yet it is impossible for them ever to be uniform. So, accordingly, we should always propose that there is rest in uniformity, and motion in non-uniformity. And, furthermore, the cause of the non-uniform nature is inequality.

57e

Timaeus: We have, indeed, described the origin of inequality, but we have not said precisely why there is not a cessation of their motion and mutual interchange once each of the four has been separated according to their kinds. We shall resume our account of this topic now. Since the circuit of the Universe encompasses these four kinds, and, being circular, is also inclined by nature to revert towards itself, it compresses them all and tends to allow no empty space to remain. Therefore, fire has indeed penetrated everything else to the greatest extent, air to the second greatest extent since it is by nature second in degree of fineness, and so on for all the others. For those formed from the largest components leave the most empty space in their structure, while the smallest leave the least. So the coming together, or compression, forces the smaller into the spaces in the larger. Now, when the smaller are placed alongside the

larger and the lesser split the greater apart, or the larger force the lesser to combine, they are all borne in one direction or another towards their own locations, for as each changes in size, it also changes the position of the location that belongs to it. In this way, and on account of all this, the generation of non-uniformity is always preserved, and it continually produces the unceasing alteration of these bodies, now and in the future.

58c

Timaeus: As well as this, we need to realise also that numerous types of fire exist, flame for instance, and also that which is emitted by flame which does not burn and yet provides light to the eyes, and also that which remains in the glowing embers when the flame is extinguished. The same goes for air, the brightest is referred to as ether, the murkiest as mist and darkness, and there are other forms without names, generated through the inequality of the triangles. The forms of water are first divided in two, one form of it is liquid, the other liquefiable. Now, the liquid form, because it partakes of the kinds of water that are small and unequal, is readily moved, either just by itself or by something else, due to the non-uniformity and the characteristic associated with its shape. However, the one composed of large and uniform kinds is more immobile than the liquid, and since it is rendered solid by its uniformity, it is heavy. Yet if it is penetrated and broken apart by fire, it loses its uniformity, and once this is undone it is more inclined towards motion, and once it becomes mobile it is extended out upon the earth under the pressure of the surrounding air. Each of these processes has acquired a name. 'Melting' is the disintegration of the bulk, and 'flowing' is the spreading upon the earth. But when the fire is expelled from there again, it does not emerge into a void; the surrounding air is pressurised, and it compresses the still mobile liquid mass into the positions that belonged to fire, thus mixing it together with itself. And once this is compressed it acquires its uniformity again, and since

fire, the artificer of its non-uniformity, has withdrawn, it reverts to sameness with itself. Being quit of fire is termed 'cooling', while the contraction that follows its departure is termed 'being in a solid state'.

59b

Timaeus: Now, of all these liquefiable kinds of water, as we have called them, the most dense arises from the finest and most uniform components. It is of one form only, glistening and yellow in colour, a most revered possession – gold, filtered through rock and solidified, while the offspring of gold, which is very hard and black due to its density, is called adamant. The kind whose parts bear the closest resemblance to gold has more forms than one. In density, it is in a way more dense than gold and it contains a small, fine portion of earth, and so it is harder, yet in another way it is lighter since it contains larger interstices within itself. This compound is copper, one form of the bright and solid types of water. But as the two components of the mixture age, they separate from one another again, and the earth that is in the mixture appears on the surface and is called rust.

59c

Timaeus: It should no longer be a complex matter to work out the features of the other substances of this kind whilst adhering to the structure of likely stories. In this regard, whenever someone, for the sake of relaxation, laying aside discussions concerning things that always are, gives consideration to likely accounts concerned with becoming, and derives a pleasure he will not later regret, he would be introducing a measured and sensible pastime into his life. So, having indulged in this just now, dealing with the same issues, we shall proceed with the likely accounts that follow this in due order in the following way. Water that is mixed with fire and is fine and liquid is called liquid due to its motion and the course it takes as it rolls along the ground. Now, it is also soft because its bases are yielding,

being less stable than those of earth, and whenever it separates off from fire and air, and is on its own, it becomes more uniform and is compressed into itself by the emerging substances, and it is solidified in this way. When this happens to it well above the earth it is hail, when on the earth it is ice, and when it happens to a lesser extent and it is still half-solidified, it is snow when above the earth, and when it is compacted from dew upon the earth it is called frost.

59e

Timaeus: Now, most types of water are mixed with one another, and because this category in general is filtered through the plants of the earth, they are called juices. Although each involves dissimilarity on account of the intermixtures, and while the differences give rise to numerous kinds that are nameless, four types containing fire are particularly evident and these have received names: wine, that can heat the soul as well as the body; an oily sort that is smooth and splits the beam of sight and so appears glittering and bright to behold – resin, castor oil, oil itself and any others with the same capacity. There is one that can relax the passageways of the mouth back to their natural condition, and by this capacity furnishes sweetness; it is generally referred to as honey. The last kind corrodes the flesh by burning; it is a foamy sort secreted from all other juices and it is called sour-juice.

60b

Timaeus: As for the forms of earth, that which is filtered through water becomes a strong material in the following manner. Whenever the water that is mixed in with it is broken up in the commingling process, it transforms into the figure of air, and once it has become air it rises up to its own region, but there isn't a void above them, so the air in the vicinity is pressurised. And since it is heavy, it presses down and pours around the mass of earth, squeezes it intensely and compresses it into the positions from which the newly formed air had

arisen. And earth, when compressed by air, constitutes stone that is indissoluble in water. The superior kind composed of equal and uniform parts is transparent, while the opposite applies to the inferior kind. The one from which all the moisture has been forced out by the rapid action of fire, and is a more brittle compound than the other, is the kind to which we have given the name 'potters' clay'. And on occasion, when some moisture is left behind and the earth has been melted by fire and then cooled down, the black-coloured substance constitutes [lava] stone. Similarly, there are two more that are extracted from the mixture containing a great deal of water. They are composed of finer particles of earth and are salty, and being semi-solid they are soluble once more in water. One is soda, which can cleanse us of oil and earth, while the other is salt, which blends well in the interactions associated with sense perception of the mouth, and, according to tradition, is beloved of the gods. The compounds of both earth and water that can be dissolved by fire but not by water are compacted in that way for the following reason. A mass of earth is not broken up by fire or air, since their particles are naturally smaller than the structure of its interstices. So they pass through the considerable open spaces without exertion, leaving the earth undissolved and rendering it indissoluble. However, since the particles of water are naturally larger, they make their way through by force, loosening the earth and breaking it apart. So earth that is not forcibly solidified in this way is dissolved only by water, yet when it has been so solidified, it is dissolved by nothing but fire, for no way is left for anything to enter it except fire.

60e

Timaeus: Water, for its part, when compressed with extreme force, is dispersed by fire alone, but if the force of compression is weaker, it is dispersed by both fire and air. Air acts upon the interstices, fire upon the elemental triangles. And when air is forcibly solidified, nothing dissolves it except by acting upon its

elemental triangles, and when the solidification is not forceful, only fire can break it apart.

61a

Timaeus: In the case of the mixed bodies composed of earth and water, as long as water occupies its interstices and these are forcibly pressed together, the particles of water arriving from outside, having no way of entering, flow around it leaving the entire mass intact. Yet the particles of fire entering the interstices of the water and acting upon it – fire acting on water as water acted upon earth – constitute the sole causes whereby the compound body is broken apart and flows. Some of these, the entire category associated with glass and any stones that we call liquefiable, happen to have less water than earth. Others – all materials that are wax-like or useful as incense – have, for their part, more water.

61c

Timaeus: Although the variegated forms originating from the commonalities in the shapes and their transformations into one another have been presented quite well at this stage, we should nevertheless attempt to indicate the causes by which the characteristics they possess have arisen. Firstly, the characteristics we are discussing throughout must be perceptible, even though the origin of flesh and its accompaniments, and of the mortal part of soul, have not yet been described. In fact, it is not possible for these to be adequately discussed without reference to those characteristics that are amenable to sense perception, or to discuss the characteristics without reference to the senses, while it is nigh impossible to treat of both at the same time. So, we should first make assumptions about one or the other of them, and then return to those assumptions hereafter. So, let us initially make an assumption about whatever is relevant to body and soul, so that, having described the various kinds we may next speak of their qualities.

61e

Timaeus: Now, let's first look at why we refer to fire as hot by considering the splitting and cutting we notice it bringing about in our bodies. Indeed, we all perceive that the effect is a piercing one, yet we must deduce the fineness of the edges, the sharpness of the angles, the smallness of the particles and the rapidity of its motion, all of which render it intense and incisive, always cutting acutely into whatever it encounters. We deduce this by remembering the origin of its shape, whereby this substance and no other, by splitting our bodies and cutting them up minutely, is likely to provide the characteristic we now call heat and its name too.²⁶ Although what is opposite to these is obvious, it deserves to be described anyway. Now, when the liquids consisting of larger particles surrounding the body make their way in, they force the smaller particles out, but are unable to settle into the positions thus vacated. They compress the moisture within us, rendering it immobile and solid due to the uniformity and the pressure, whereas it had previously been non-uniform and mobile. But anything that is unnaturally contracted naturally resists the process by pushing back in the opposite direction. This resistance and shaking is called shuddering or shivering, while the entire effect as a whole, and that which brings it about, has the name 'cold'. 'Hard' designates anything to which our flesh yields, while 'soft' designates anything which yields to the flesh, and they are also designated in this way with respect to one another. Whatever rests upon a small base tends to yield, and whatever is constituted of square bases is the most rigid form, since it is established firmly, and anything compressed to an extreme density would also be especially resistant.

62c

Timaeus: The nature of heavy and light may be presented most clearly by considering them along with the expressions 'up' and 'down'. Indeed, it is not at all correct to regard the Universe as

naturally divided into two distinct opposite regions; 'down' being the one towards which anything with any bodily bulk is borne; 'up' being the direction in which everything moves against its will. For since the entire Heaven has a spherical form, any extremities are situated at an equal distance from the centre, and these by nature must be extremities in the same way, while the centre, being situated at an equal distance from all the extremities, must be regarded as being in the opposite position to all of them. Now, since the world is naturally like this, which of the locations we have described may be designated as 'up' or 'down' without being regarded, quite rightly, as using a name that is not appropriate? For the central location within it is not rightly described as either 'up' or 'down'. No, it is just in the centre, while the periphery is obviously not the centre, nor does any part thereof differ in its relationship to the centre, nor to any of the points on the opposite side. But what sort of opposing names may be applied to something that is similar in every respect, and in what way might it be properly described? Indeed, even if a solid body were equipoised at the centre of the Universe, it would never be borne towards any particular extremity since they are all similar in every respect. No, even if someone were to proceed around it in a circle, repeatedly standing with his feet in opposite situations, he would refer to the same point on it as both 'up' and 'down'. Indeed, as we said just now, the whole is spherical in form, so it is not sensible to describe one location as 'up' and another as 'down'. As for the origin of these names and the actual circumstances to which they apply, by reason of which we are accustomed to refer to the entire Universe by dividing it in this way, these issues we must agree upon by making the following supposition. Suppose someone in the region of the Universe that is assigned predominantly to fire, where most of it gathers and towards which it is borne, were to stand up there and had the ability to take portions of fire, place

them on a scale and weigh them, raising the beam and dragging the fire forcibly into the dissimilar region of air, a lesser quantity of fire obviously would be forced more easily than a greater. For if two things are raised aloft by a single effort, the lesser must presumably go along with the force to a greater extent, and the greater to a lesser extent as it resists the process. So, the large volume is said to be heavy and to be borne downwards, while the small one is said to be light and borne upwards.

63b

Timaeus: Well, we need to discover ourselves doing the very same thing in our own region. Indeed, when we stand upon the earth, weighing earthy substances and sometimes earth itself, we are dragging them forcibly and contrary to nature into the dissimilar region of air. In both cases they cling to their own kindred, but the smaller bulk co-operates with the compulsion more easily and is first to follow it into the dissimilar region. Accordingly, we refer to it as 'light', and the region into which we compel it as 'up', and the characteristics opposite to these as 'heavy' and 'down'. Consequently, these must behave differently relative to one another because the vast bulk of the four types occupy regions opposite to one another. Indeed, on comparing what is light in one region with light in the opposite region, heavy with heavy, down with down, and up with up, all sorts of direct or indirect oppositions and differences relative to one another will be discovered, some present, some coming into being. However, there is one factor to be kept in mind in all of these cases. The course towards what is kindred to each renders whatever transverse it, heavy, and the region into which something like this is borne, down. The other terms are applied to those that take the other course. So, let's declare that these are the explanations of those characteristics. As for roughness and smoothness, I presume that anyone would be able to discern their causes and relate them to someone else, for one is

produced by hardness combined with non-uniformity, and the other by uniformity combined with density.

64a

Timaeus: The most significant remaining issue concerning the experiences shared by the entire body is the cause of the pleasures and the pains in those processes we have already described, and in any cases where sense perceptions acquired through our body parts are also accompanied by pains and pleasures in the parts themselves. Now, we should come to an understanding of the causes of any effect, perceptible or imperceptible, by recollecting the distinction we made earlier between the mobile and the immobile nature. Yes, anything we intend to discover must be pursued in this way. Whenever an impression, even a slight one, is made upon anything that is mobile by nature, it is transmitted around, one part bringing about the same effect upon the next until it reaches the thinking and proclaims the characteristics of whatever made that impression. While in the opposite case, where the object is unmoving, there is no outward motion, and the object alone is affected without moving anything else in its vicinity, so that the initial impression is not transmitted from one part to another, does not move into the living creature in its entirety, and renders the impression imperceptible. These considerations apply to bone and hair and any other predominantly earthy parts of our bodies, while the previous considerations apply mainly to parts concerned with sight and hearing because of the significant function of fire and air within them.

64c

Timaeus: Now, we should think about pleasure and pain as follows. When a sudden, forceful impression contrary to our nature is made upon us, it is painful, while the sudden return once more to the natural condition is pleasant. Any impression that is gentle and gradual is imperceptible, but the opposite goes for the opposite impressions. Anything that happens easily

is undoubtedly perceptible, and yet it does not involve pain or pleasure – experiences associated with the beam of sight itself, for instance, which, as we said previously, constitutes a body that coalesces with our own in the daytime. For cuts and burns, and whatever else the beam of light undergoes, do not produce pain or pleasure either when it returns once more to the same configuration. Yet there are significant and detailed sense impressions corresponding to whatever affects it, and to anything that it impinges upon or comes into contact with, for there is no force whatsoever involved in its dispersal or reconstitution. However, bodies composed of larger particles yield with difficulty to whatever acts upon them, transmit the effects throughout their entirety, and involve pleasures and pains; pains when they are being altered from their normal state, pleasures when they are being established once more in their original condition. In cases where they undergo gradual depletion and emptying but the refilling is sudden and extensive, the emptying process is imperceptible and the filling process is perceptible, and this induces no pains in the mortal part of the soul, only enormous pleasures. An obvious example is our experience of pleasant odours. But cases in which they are suddenly altered from their usual condition, and re-established only gradually and with difficulty in their own original state, bring about outcomes completely opposite to the previous cases. This is evident in circumstances in which the body is cut or burned.

65b

Timaeus: Although the experiences common to the body as a whole and any names bestowed upon whatever produces them have been described fairly well, we should still attempt to explain, if we can somehow do so, what happens in various parts of our bodies, the associated effects, and furthermore the causes involved in their production. First, we should clarify as best we can whatever we omitted from our earlier discussion

about tastes – namely, the particular experiences that involve the tongue. These experiences appear to originate, as indeed do most others, from certain constrictions and expansions, and, additionally, they rely more than the others upon roughness and smoothness. For any earth particles that enter in around the veins that act like probes for the tongue, extending as far as the heart, fall upon the moist, soft flesh, get dissolved, constrict the veins and dry them up. These appear harsh to us if they are particularly rough, dry if they are less rough. But anything that cleanses these veins, and anything that rinses the region of the tongue, is referred to as bitter when it exceeds the measure of its activity so that it attacks and melts away the substance of the tongue itself. Soda has this sort of effect, while those that are milder than soda and exercise their cleansing effect in due measure appear salty to us and more agreeable in the absence of that bitter roughness. Those which combine with the heat of the mouth and are rendered smooth become inflamed along with it, and in turn burn the very thing that warmed them up. Then, being carried upwards by their lightness towards the sense organs in the head, they cut apart whatever they impinge upon, and because they possess these powers, all such substances are called pungent. Those particles that have become thin through decay sink down into the narrow veins and are duly proportioned to particles of earth and air that are in there already, so that they set them moving around one another and stir them up. Being stirred up, they form an enclosure, and as one kind of particle sinks into another they produce hollows stretched around the particles that enter. So when a hollow of moisture, earthy or pure, is stretched about air, it forms watery vessels of air. Those enveloped by pure water are transparent and are called bubbles, while in cases where the moisture is earthy so that it moves and rises in a mass, we use the terms foaming and fermentation, and that which causes these experiences is called acid.

66c

Timaeus: An effect opposite to all those we have been describing is produced by an opposite cause. Whenever the configuration of the particles entering into liquids has a natural affinity with the normal condition of the tongue, smoothes it out and covers over its roughness, contracts the parts that have been unnaturally dilated, relaxes those that have been unnaturally constricted and settles them all as much as possible into their natural condition, anything of this sort constitutes a pleasant and agreeable remedy for those violent experiences, and is called sweet.

66d

Timaeus: Well, that is enough on this topic. Now, in the case of the power that belongs to the nostrils there are no distinct forms, for all of the smells are half-breeds and no single form proves to possess symmetry corresponding to any smell. Rather, the veins within us that are involved in these processes are more narrowly constructed than the kinds of particle belonging to earth and water, and are wider than those of fire and air, so no one has ever perceived a scent from any of these four. No, odour arises from the moistening, decaying, liquefaction or evaporation of substances. Indeed, odours arise at the intermediate stage when water is being transformed into air or air into water, and they are all smoke or mist. The one proceeding from air to water is mist, while the one proceeding from water to air is smoke. Therefore, all odours are less dense than water and yet more dense than air. This is most evident when someone impedes the inward breath and then draws his breath forcibly, for when he does this no accompanying odour whatsoever is filtered through, and the breath alone enters in, devoid of odours. Now, the varieties of scents fall into two categories which are without names, and consist neither of numerous forms nor of a simple few. Rather, we should speak only of an immediate, distinct, twofold division into the

pleasant and the painful: one roughens and does violence to the entire vessel that lies between our navel and the top of our head, while the other soothes this same region and lovingly restores it once more to its natural condition.

67a

Timaeus: The third part of sense perception within us, the one concerned with hearing, should be investigated, and the causes of the experiences associated therewith should be stated. Now, we may propose, in general, that sound is an impact transmitted by the air through the ears, brain and blood as far as the soul, and that hearing is the motion produced by this, a motion beginning in the head and ending in the region around the liver. If the motion is rapid the sound is high-pitched, if slow it is low-pitched, if it is uniform the sound is even and smooth, and in the opposite case it is harsh. If the motion is extensive, the sound is loud, and in the opposite case it is faint. However, the factors involved in the concord of sound must be dealt with in later deliberations.

67c

Timaeus: Well, there remains a fourth kind of sense perception, and it is necessary to subdivide this since enormous variations are included within it, which we refer to collectively as colour, a flame emanating from bodies, having particles proportionate to the beam of sight so as to bring about perception. And in the earlier accounts the causes that generated the visual beam were simply stated. Therefore, it would be most reasonable and appropriate to present a suitable account dealing with colours as follows. Particles borne from the various objects and impinging upon the beam of sight may be smaller, larger, or indeed equal in size to the particles belonging to the visual beam itself. Now, those that are equal in size are imperceptible, and, indeed, we say they are transparent. The larger and the smaller constrict the beam in one case, and disperse it in the other, and these are related to the particles that warm and cool

the flesh, the astringent ones associated with the tongue, and those we referred to as pungent due to their warming effect. White and black constitute identical experiences to these, but in a different medium, and for these reasons the phenomena appear different. Therefore, they should be referred to accordingly – that which disperses the beam of sight is white, and its opposite is black. And when the more rapid motion belonging to a different kind of fire impinges upon the beam of sight and disperses it right up to the eyes, forcibly compressing and cutting the very passageways of the eyes themselves, it causes a volume of fire and water, which we call a tear, to pour out of them. This more acute motion, being itself fire, encounters fire coming from the opposite direction which leaps out as if coming from a flash of lightning, while the incoming fire is being extinguished in the moisture, and in this turmoil a whole variety of colours is generated. We refer to the effect as dazzling, and we call whatever brings this about bright and glistening.

68a

Timaeus: The kind of fire that is intermediate between these other two is not glistening, despite reaching the moisture of the eyes and mixing with it, and the beam of fire shining through the moisture with which it is mixed produces a blood colour that we call red. Bright mixed with red and white becomes orange, but it would not be sensible to state the extent of the measure involved in these, even if we knew it, since we would not be even moderately capable of proposing any necessity or any likely account thereof. And yet, red mixed with black and white is purple, or it is violet whenever these components are burned and more black is mixed in with them. Orange arises from a mixture of yellow and grey, while grey comes from white and black, and ochre from white mixed with yellow. White mixed with bright and steeped in an intense black produces a dark blue colour, and dark blue mixed with white is light blue,

while orange mixed with black is green. As for the other colours, it is fairly obvious from these examples what mixtures they should be attributed to if we are to preserve our likely account. Yet if someone were to put these matters to the test through practical investigation, he would be acting in ignorance of the distinction between human and divine nature. God has sufficient knowledge and power to combine the many into one, and then again, to separate the one into many, but no human being is now, or ever shall be, adequate to either of these undertakings.

68e

Timaeus: So, at this stage, all these have developed in this way out of necessity. The artificer of the most beautiful and best of whatever comes into being took these over when he was bringing the self-sufficient and perfect god to birth, employing the causes associated with these as subservient, while he himself fashioned the good in whatever comes into being. Therefore, we should distinguish two kinds of cause, one necessary, the other divine, and we should seek the divine in all things for the sake of attaining a life that is as happy as our nature will admit. And we should seek the necessary for the sake of the divine, reckoning that without these necessities, those divine objects, our serious concern, are incapable of being discerned on their own, nor can they be apprehended or shared in at all.

69a

Timaeus: Now that the two kinds of cause have been duly separated and lie before us like materials for a carpenter, we must weave the remaining account together from these two. Let's briefly go back again to the beginning, proceed quickly from there to the stage we have just arrived at, and attempt to give a conclusion to our story at that stage, a crown befitting all that has gone before. Indeed, just as we said at the outset, these were all in a disorderly state when the god engendered

symmetry in each of them, each in relation to itself and all in relation to one another, to the extent that, and in the manner that, it was possible for them to be proportionate and symmetrical. For at that time nothing had a share in these proportions save by chance, and there was nothing at all worthy of being called by the names we now use, such as fire or water or any of the others. Rather, he first set all of these in order, then constructed this Universe from them, a single living being containing within itself all living beings, both mortal and immortal. He himself became the artificer of the divine beings and he commanded his own offspring to undertake the creation of the mortals. And they, imitating their father, received the immortal beginning of soul, then fashioned a mortal body in a globe around it and bestowed the entire body as its vehicle, and also built another form of soul in the body – the mortal form. This contains fearsome, necessary experiences within itself; first, there are pleasures, the greatest lure to evil; then, there are pains, taking flight from the good; there is also rashness, and fear, two unintelligent advisers; anger that is so hard to appease; and hope, so easily led astray. Mixing these together with irrational sense perception, and a love that will turn its hand to anything, they compounded the mortal kind of soul in a necessary manner. And fearing that these might pollute the divine part, unless this was absolutely unavoidable, they housed the mortal part of soul separately from that in a different dwelling place in the body, by constructing an isthmus and a boundary between the head and the chest, the neck, which they put in place so as to keep them separated.

69e

Timaeus: Then they fastened the mortal kind of soul within the chest, or thorax as we call it, and since one part of this is naturally better and another part worse, they built the vessel of the thorax, making a division therein as if they were separating the men's quarters from the women's by placing the midriff as a

barrier between the two. Then they housed the part of the soul that partakes of courage and spirit, the part that is fond of victory, closer to the head between the midriff and the neck, so that it could hearken to reason, and share with it the task of forcibly restraining the tribe of desires on occasions when they would not willingly consent in any way to obey the injunction of reason issuing from the Acropolis. So, in the sentry house they situated the heart, a knot of veins and a fountain for the blood that is borne relentlessly through all the limbs. Consequently, whenever the force of spirit boils up because reason proclaims that some unjust action is affecting them from the outside, or even from the internal desires, every sensible part of the body rapidly becomes aware of the exhortations and threats communicated through all the narrow veins, heeds them and follows them unreservedly, and, accordingly, the very best part is allowed to rule among them all.

70c

Timaeus: Considering the pounding of the heart, due to expectation of terrors or the awakening of spirit, and anticipating that this sort of swelling of the spirited parts was going to arise through fire, they devised a protection for the heart by implanting the structure of the lung. First and foremost this is soft and bloodless, and it also has cavities bored through it like a sponge so that it may receive air and liquid, have a cooling effect, and provide respite and ease amid the burning heat. Accordingly, they cut the channels of the windpipe as far as the lungs, and wrapped the lungs around the heart like a buffer so that when spirit bursts forth within the heart, it would pound against something yielding and be relieved, and being less troubled it would be more able to join with spirit in the service of reason.

70d

Timaeus: As for the part of the soul that is desirous of food and drink, and whatever else is held to be lacking on account of the

nature of the body, that part they housed in between the midriff and the boundary near the navel, occupying the entire region, building there a sort of feeding trough for the nourishment of the body. And there they tethered this part, like a conjoined wild beast that needed to be nourished if there was ever going to be a mortal race. So they allocated this location to it so that, grazing constantly at the feeding trough, housed as far away as possible from the part that deliberates, producing the least possible commotion and noise, it would allow the supreme part to deliberate in peace about what best serves the individual and the entire community. And they realised that it was not going to understand reason, and even if it were somehow to attain some appreciation thereof, it would not be in its nature to be concerned about any words, but would be utterly enchanted night and day by images and phantoms. God, seeking to exploit this particular weakness, assembled the structure of the liver and placed it in that very dwelling place, arranging that it be dense, smooth and bright, possessing both sweetness and bitterness. It was intended that the power belonging to the concepts emanating from nous, moving in the liver as if in a mirror that receives impressions and produces visible images, would strike fear into the appetitive part. So, whenever this power makes use of a kindred portion of the liver's bitterness, bears down upon it strongly and threateningly, and rapidly spreads the bitterness over the entire liver, it projects bilious colours, contracts it and makes it all shrivelled and rough. What's more, it also bends the lobe of the liver from its proper state, constricts it, blocks and closes its ducts and apertures, and brings about pain and nausea. And yet, when some breath of gentleness emanating from mind paints pictures of an opposite sort, it provides respite from the bitterness by refusing to set in motion or even to touch the nature that is opposite to itself. Then, making use of the very sweetness that is natural to the liver, it restores all its parts to their proper, smooth and free

condition, and renders the part of the soul housed in the region of the liver kind and gentle, spending the hours of night in due measure by having recourse to prophecy whilst sleeping, since it does not have a share in reason or intelligence.

71d

Timaeus: Indeed, those who fashioned us, remembering the injunction of their father when he directed them to make the mortal race as excellent as possible, even corrected the degenerate part of us in this way by establishing the prophetic power in the liver so that it would have some contact with truth. And there is sufficient indication that God has bestowed prophecy upon unintelligent humanity from the fact that no one in possession of nous attains to God-inspired true prophecy, but only someone whose power of intelligence is fettered in sleep or who is disturbed by disease or some frenzy. Rather, it is the role of the intelligent person to recollect and reflect upon the utterances from the prophetic or frenzied state, waking or dreaming, and upon any visions that were seen, and to decide by reasoning how and for whom these all indicate some present, past or future good or evil. However, it is not a task for the person who still remains in the prophetic state to judge the visions and utterances originating from himself. No, it has been well stated of old that it belongs only to the sound-minded person to know himself and do what is his own. Hence, it is the custom to set a group of interpreters as judges over the God-inspired prophecies, interpreters whom some refer to as prophets in their own right, being totally unaware that these people are interpreters of the enigmatic utterances or visions, and may not rightly be called prophets, but interpreters of those who engage in prophecy.

72b

Timaeus: So then, it is for the sake of prophecy that the liver has a nature of this sort and is located in the place we have described, and, while each creature is still alive, such an organ

as this retains more vivid indications, but when deprived of life it becomes blind and its prophecies are too obscure to indicate anything definite. Furthermore, it is for the sake of the liver, in order to keep it always bright and clean, that the organ next to it has the composition it has and is positioned to the left, like a cloth supplied for a mirror, always lying ready by its side. So, whenever any impurities arise in the region of the liver due to bodily diseases, they are all purified and absorbed by the loose texture of the spleen, since its fabric is porous and devoid of blood. Accordingly, as it fills up with impurities, it waxes large and it festers, but then again, once the body has been purified, it reduces in size and subsides to its former condition.

72d

Timaeus: As for the soul, the extent to which it is mortal and the extent to which it is divine, and how, in what company, and for what reasons these two parts are housed separately, we could only ever insist that what we have asserted is true if God were to confirm it. But we should dare to assert, even at this stage, that what has been said is likely, and will prove more so on further investigation, so let that be our statement. Well, the topic that follows from these should be pursued on the same basis. This concerns the manner in which the rest of the body came into being. It would be most appropriate to attribute its construction to reasoning of the following sort. The race of gods who framed us knew that we would show a lack of restraint with regard to food and drink, and would consume them greedily beyond due measure or necessity. So, to prevent our rapid destruction through diseases, and avoid the immediate demise of the still immature race of mortals, they anticipated these problems and put in place the receptacle we call the abdomen to retain the excess food and drink. They twisted the structure of the entrails around inside this so that food would not pass through so rapidly that it would immediately compel the body to need food once again, thus producing insatiable

desire and rendering our entire race unphilosophic and uncultured due to gluttony, heedless of our most divine part.

73b

Timaeus: In relation to bones, flesh and any substances of this sort, the following account applies. The origin of all these is the production of marrow, for whilst the soul is conjoined with the body, the bonds of life, bound fast in marrow, are the secure roots of the mortal race. And yet the marrow itself has come into being from other materials. For the god separated out those primary triangles that were unwarped and smooth and best able to produce fire, water, air and earth in a precise manner, and set each of these apart from their own kinds. Having mixed these with one another in due proportion, he devised a universal seed-mixture for the entire mortal race by fashioning marrow from them, and after that he planted therein the various kinds of soul and bound them fast. In his initial allocation, he divided the marrow immediately into shapes corresponding in number and type to the shapes that were to belong to the particular forms of soul. He moulded into a complete sphere the portion of marrow that was about to receive the divine seed into itself, as if it were ploughed land, and this he called the brain, implying that the head²⁷ was going to become the container for the brain once the construction of each living creature had been completed. Furthermore, he divided the portion of marrow that was to retain the remaining part of soul, the mortal part, into shapes that were both round and elongated at the same time, and yet he referred to them all as marrow. He also cast out fetters of the entire soul from these as if they were being thrown from anchors, and then fashioned all of this body of ours around the marrow after he had constructed a complete covering of bone to surround it.

73e

Timaeus: He constructed bone as follows. He sifted out earth that was pure and smooth, kneaded it, soaked it in marrow, then

placed it in fire, and after that he plunged it into water, again into fire, and then into water once more. So, by constantly transferring it in this way from one medium to the other, it was rendered indissoluble by either of them. Making use of this, he turned a sphere of bone around the brain of the creature and he left a narrow opening in the sphere. He also moulded vertebrae out of bone to surround the marrow that runs through the neck and down the spine, arranging them vertically like pivots beginning from the head and running down the whole trunk. And so they preserved the entire seed by fencing it about with a stone-like enclosure, creating joints and making use of the quality of difference within these as an intermediate power, introduced for the sake of motion and flexibility.

74a

Timaeus: Furthermore, he recognised the tendency of the bony material to be more brittle and inflexible than it should be, prone to become inflamed and then cool down again, thus developing gangrene and bringing rapid destruction to the seed within. On account of these tendencies, he devised the sinews and the flesh so that sinews would bind all the limbs together and would enable the body to bend and stretch by contracting and relaxing about the pivots, while the flesh was to be a barrier against heat and a protection against cold, and against falls too, because it would yield softly and gently to objects, just like garments of felt. It also contains warm moisture within itself that breaks out in sweat, providing a coolness of its own to the entire body by moistening it on the outside in the summer. Then again, in winter it uses this same fire to provide a measure of defence against the onslaught of the prevailing frost that surrounds it. Bearing this in mind, he who shaped us mixed water, fire and earth together, harmonised them, and compounded a ferment from acid and brine which he added to the mix, thus producing soft, succulent flesh. And he compounded the sinews from a blend of bone and unfermented

flesh, a single substance with qualities intermediate between the two, to which he added a yellow colour. Hence, the sinews acquired the quality of being tighter and tougher than flesh but softer and more moist than bone. The god enclosed the bones and the marrow within these sinews, used them to bind the bones together, and then placed a covering of flesh over them all.

74e

Timaeus: Now, whatever bones were most possessed of soul he fenced about with the least amount of flesh, while those that had least soul received most flesh, and that was extremely dense. And, indeed, he caused very little flesh to grow at the joining of the bones unless reason indicated some necessity that it be there. This was to prevent flesh from acting as an impediment to the bending of the joints, thus making the body stiff and hard to move. Furthermore, lots of dense and extremely compressed flesh would be so hard that it would make perception difficult and render the mental faculties unretentive and dull. Because of this, the thighs and shins are fully endowed with flesh, and so is the area around the hips and the region of the upper arms and forearms, any other unjointed parts of our bodies, and any internal bones that are deficient in intelligence due to the paucity of soul in their marrow. The parts possessing intelligence are less endowed, except when he somehow fashioned flesh just for the sake of perception itself, like the structure of the tongue, but in most cases it is as I have said. Indeed, the nature that arises from necessity and develops along with it does not in any way allow dense bone and lots of flesh to be simultaneous with keen sense perception. For if these two qualities were actually willing to occur simultaneously, it would be best of all for the structure of the head to possess them, so that the human race, bearing upon itself a fleshy, sinewy and strong head, could attain a life twice or many times as long as the present one, healthier too, and

more free from pain.

75b

Timaeus: But it so happened that the artificers responsible for bringing us into existence, deliberating on whether they should produce a long-lived inferior race or a short-lived superior race, decided that the shorter, better life should be chosen unreservedly for everyone, in preference to the longer and inferior life. Accordingly, they covered the head completely with thin bones, but not with flesh or with sinews either, since it does not possess any joints. So, based on all these considerations, a more perceptive, more intelligent, but much weaker head was placed upon the body of every person. For these reasons, the god situated the sinews at the base of the head in a circle around the neck and glued them on by means of uniformity, and to these he attached the extremities of the jaws under the structure of the face. The rest of the sinews he distributed among all of the limbs, connecting them together joint by joint. And indeed, those who brought order to the features of our mouth arranged it as it now is, fitting it with teeth, a tongue and lips for the sake of all that is necessary and all that is most exalted, thus devising an inward passage with a view to the necessary, and outward passage with a view to the most exalted. Indeed, all that passes in bringing nourishment to the body is necessary, while the stream of words flowing outwards in the service of understanding is the most beautiful and exalted of all streams.

75d

Timaeus: Furthermore, due to the excesses of the various seasons, it was not possible to leave the head only as bare bone, or, on the other hand, to let it become dull and unperceptive because it was overborne by a mass of flesh. So, from the fleshy material that was not dried up, an excessively loose film was separated out which we now refer to as skin. Because of the moisture around the brain, this skin combined with itself, grew

in a circle and completely enveloped the head. Then the moisture emerging from the sutures watered it and closed it in at the crown, drawing it all together into a kind of knot, and the structure of these sutures became variegated due to the effect of the inner orbits and of the nutriment; the greater the conflict between the two orbits, the more sutures there were, the lesser the conflict, the fewer the sutures.

76b

Timaeus: Now, the divine part²⁸ pierced this skin all around, and once it had been perforated, any pure moisture and pure heat in the liquid that emerged from it evaporated, while the mixed substance that the skin was also made from rose up on account of the movement, and stretched out at some length. It was as fine as the tiny piercings, yet because it was slow moving it was pushed back under the skin again by the external air that surrounded it, coiled around itself, and took root. So the hair grew on the skin due to these effects, kindred thereto because it was fibrous, yet harder and more dense due to the solidification that derived from the cooling process which cooled and compressed each hair as it separated from the skin. With this, our maker made the head woolly by making use of the factors we have described, intending that hair, rather than flesh, should be the cover for the area around the brain to ensure its safety, still providing sufficient shade in summer and shelter in winter without becoming an impediment that would prevent proper perception.

76d

Timaeus: From the combination of sinew, skin and bone, dried out to form a single substance from all three, a hard skin developed, twined around the end of the fingers. Although it was produced by these three subsidiary causes, it was wrought nevertheless by an ultimate intentional cause with a view to subsequent generations, for those who framed us knew that at some stage women and the beasts would arise from men, and

they also understood that many of the animals would require the use of claws or talons for numerous purposes. Therefore, as soon as humans came into existence, they gave them traces of the structure of claws. So, based on this reasoning, and with these motives, they caused skin, hair and nails to grow at the extremities of the limbs.

77a

Timaeus: Once all the parts and limbs of the mortal creature had developed into a natural unity, and it proved necessary for such creatures to spend their lives exposed to wind and fire, be wasted and depleted by these and perish as a result, the gods devised a means of helping them. By mixing various characteristics and kinds of perception, they brought about the development of a nature akin to human nature, a living being of a different sort. These are the domesticated trees, plants and seeds that have been trained by husbandry into the cultivated forms that we possess. Before that, there were only the uncultivated forms which are older than our cultivated varieties. Indeed, anything that partakes of life may justifiably and correctly be described as a living being,²⁹ yet that which we are speaking of now partakes of the third form of soul, the form that our account situated between the midriff and the navel, the form that has no involvement with opinion, reasoning or nous, but only with pleasant and painful sensations and their accompanying desires. For it is always completely passive, and its origin has not given it the natural ability to reflect upon and discern any aspects of itself by turning inwards, being concerned with itself, shunning external motion and having recourse to its own motion. So it is alive, and although it is a living creature it is stationary, rooted to the spot, stuck because it is bereft of motion of its own.

77c

Timaeus: Now, once the superior beings had caused everything of this sort to grow as nutriment for us lesser creatures, they

made conduits through the body itself, as if they were cutting channels in gardens, so that it would be watered by a sort of incoming stream. In the first place, seeing that the body has a twofold structure with a left side and right side, they cut two veins along the back to act as channels hidden beneath the conjunction of the skin with the flesh. They also brought these down along the spine, enclosing the reproductive marrow between them so that this would flourish to the greatest extent possible, and so that the influx of liquid that flowed so easily from there because of the downward course would provide uniform irrigation to the other regions. Then, having split apart the veins around the head, they intertwined them and sent them in opposite directions, so that those on the left were bent to the right side of the body, those on the right, to the left. This, along with the skin, was to act as a bond between the head and the body since there were no sinews all around the crown of the head. What's more, it would also enable the experience of the sense impressions coming from either of the two sides to be fully revealed to the entire body.

77e

Timaeus: At that stage they facilitated the transport of liquid in the manner we shall now describe, but it will be easier to see this once we have first come to an agreement on the following point. Anything composed of smaller particles repels the larger particles, while those composed of larger particles are unable to repel the smaller particles. Fire consists of the smallest particles of them all, so it passes through water, earth, air, and anything composed of these, and nothing is able to repel it. Well, we should bear the same principle in mind in relation to our own abdomen; it retains any food or drink that falls into it, yet it is unable to retain air or fire because these consist of particles that are smaller than its own structure. Therefore, the god made use of air and fire for the distribution of moisture from the abdomen to the veins by weaving a mesh, like a fish trap, having

two ducts at its entrance, one of which he proceeded to weave once more into a forked structure. Then he extended cords of some sort from the ducts in a circle throughout the entire mesh as far as its extremities. He constructed everything within the mesh from fire; the ducts and the vessel he constructed from air.

78c

Timaeus: He then took this structure and positioned it around the creature he had fashioned, in some such manner as follows. He let the part consisting of funnels down into the mouth, and since it had a twofold structure, he lowered one part into the lungs by way of the windpipe, and the other alongside the windpipe into the abdomen. He divided the first of these in two and gave each part alike an entrance through the channels of the nose, so that when the other channel through the mouth was not working, all of its streams would be filled up from this one. He caused the rest of the vessel that constitutes the fish trap to grow around the hollow part of the body and made it all flow together gently into the ducts, since these were made of air. And then he made the ducts flow back out again. Because the body is porous, the mesh sinks into it and emerges once more, while the rays of fire bound fast within it follow both movements of the air, and this does not cease as long as the mortal creature holds together. And we say that the name-giver has called it inhalation and exhalation. And indeed, the overall process and its effect acts as a source of nourishment and life to our bodies by irrigating and cooling them. For whenever the breath passes in or out, the inner fire connected to it follows along, and as it continually moves back and forth it passes into the abdomen, seizes upon the food and drink, dissolves them, divides them into tiny particles, draws them through the passages in the same direction it is proceeding, pours them into the veins like water going from a spring into channels, and sets the currents of the veins flowing through the body as if they

were flowing through a pipe.

79a

Timaeus: But we should look again at the process of respiration and the reason why this occurs as it now does. It is as follows. Since there is no void into which any moving body would be able to enter, yet the breath does come out of our body, one consequence is surely evident to everyone. It does not emerge into a void but displaces whatever is adjacent from its position. But whatever is displaced continually drives out whatever is adjacent to itself, and on the basis of this cycle of necessity, everything is driven around again to the position from which the breath emerged, enters in, and fills it. Because there is no void, this all happens at the same time, like the revolving of a wheel. Therefore, once the chest and lungs exhale the breath, they are filled up once more by the air surrounding the body which is driven around and sinks in because the flesh is so soft. Then again, when the air is turned in the other direction and is coming out through the body, it pushes the breath around and inwards by way of the passage of the mouth and the nostrils.

79d

Timaeus: We should presume that what is responsible for initiating these processes is this. In every living creature, the warmest of its internal parts are situated close to the blood and the veins which are like a fountain of fire residing within. This, of course, we likened to the mesh of the fish-trap, extending through the middle thereof and woven entirely from fire, while everything outside of that was made of air. Now we must accept that heat naturally proceeds outwards to its own region and towards its kindred. But there are two ways out, one emerging by way of the body, the other by way of the mouth and nostrils, so whenever it rushes one way it pushes the air around the other way, and when this is pushed around and falls into the fire it is warmed, but when it travels outwards it is cooled. Now, when the heat is changing its location and the air currents

proceeding by one of the exits become warmer, the warmer air tends to go back by way of that exit once more and travels towards its own kind, pushing the air using the other exit and driving it around. The same effect and the same response keep recurring, thus setting up a cycle that oscillates back and forth and brings about inhalation and exhalation.

80a

Timaeus: What's more, this is how we should also go about explaining the effects of medical cupping instruments, the causes of swallowing, and the behaviour of projectiles that are discharged into the air and those that travel along the ground, also any sounds that are rapid or slow, and therefore appear sharp or dull, sometimes discordant in their movement due to the lack of uniformity of the motion they produce in us, sometimes concordant due to its uniformity. Indeed, the slower motions overtake the more rapid motions that precede them, as the rapid motions are coming to a halt and have already attained uniformity with those which the slower motions impart to them when they arrive later. As the slower overtake the quicker, they do not impose another motion and cause disturbance. Rather, they initiate a slower motion based upon the faster motion which is dying away, introducing uniformity and blending together a single experience consisting of sharpness and dullness. Consequently, while these provide some pleasure to the dimwitted, they delight the enlightened folk because they provide an imitation of divine harmony arising amidst the movements of mortal beings. And consider, in particular, all the flowings of water, the descent of thunderbolts and the wondrous drawing power of amber and lodestones. In none of these cases is there any attractive force. Rather, it will be evident to anyone who investigates them methodically that there is no void, that these entities push themselves around into one another, and while they are all being divided up and combined together, each changes its

position and moves towards its own region, and by interweaving these processes with one another we get those wonderful phenomena.

80d

Timaeus: As for the effect of respiration from which our account digressed, this has arisen on the basis of these principles and through those processes. As the fire cuts up the food by rising up inside us, following along with the breath, it fills up the veins from the abdomen by the rising process which floods them with the minute particles from there. And so it is that the streams of nutriment have been set flowing throughout the whole body of every creature. The newly formed particles come from kindred substances, from fruits and vegetables, which the god caused to grow for our particular benefit to nourish us. These have taken on a variety of colours due to the commingling, yet the colour red is predominant throughout, a quality brought about by the cutting effect of fire and the impression it makes on liquid. Hence, the stream flowing through the body, the one we call blood, has the colour we have described. It is pasture for flesh and for the entire body, and each part draws liquid from there and replenishes any place that has been depleted. The process of replenishment and depletion takes place in the same way that the motion of everything in the Universe takes place, a motion that draws everything towards its own kindred. Of course, our external surroundings continually cut us up and break us apart, dispatching each form towards its own kind, while the contents of the blood, for their part, having been cut up inside us into small pieces and being surrounded by the structure of each creature as though by an enveloping Heaven, are compelled to imitate the universal motion. So each of the particles within the blood, being borne towards its kindred, replenishes once more the space that has been left empty.

81b

Timaeus: Now, whenever more is going out than is coming in, all things decay, but when less is going out they grow. So when the entire structure is young and the elemental triangles of its constituents are still new, like fresh wood, the bond holding them together is strong, and yet the overall construction is soft since it has been newly formed from marrow and nourished with milk. So when the surrounding triangles come into it from outside, the ones that the food and drink are made from, these are older and weaker than its own triangles, so it overpowers these older triangles with the new ones, cuts them up, and makes the creature grow large by nourishing it with an abundance of substances similar to its own. However, when the root of the triangles is slackened because of numerous such contests fought against many opponents over a long period of time, they are no longer able to cut the entering triangles and assimilate them to themselves. On the other hand, they themselves are easily split apart by those triangles that are coming in from outside. Every creature in this situation is overpowered and decays and the condition is called old age. And in the end, once the conjoining bonds of the triangles around the marrow endure no longer under the strain and are split apart, they in turn release the bonds of the soul, and once it is set free in accordance with nature, it flies away with pleasure. Indeed, everything contrary to nature is painful, while anything that arises naturally is pleasant. The same goes for death. When it happens as a result of disease or injury it is painful and violent, but when it comes with old age, an ending that accords with nature, it is the least painful of deaths, attended more by pleasure than by pain.

82a

Timaeus: The origin of diseases is presumably obvious to everyone. For since the body has been constructed from four constituents – earth, fire, water and air – any unnatural excess or deficiency or any removal from their own place to

somewhere alien causes disorder and disease. Furthermore, since there is more than one kind of fire and of the other constituents, the acquisition by the body of an inappropriate variety, and all phenomena of this sort, have the same effect. For when any of these arises or changes its location unnaturally, anything that was previously being cooled is warmed, what was dry becomes moist, the same goes for light and heavy, and everything changes in all sorts of ways. In fact, I maintain that only the addition or removal of same from same, on the same basis and in due proportion, will allow something to remain the same as itself, sound and healthy, while anything entering or leaving that strikes a discordant note by transgressing any of these requirements will engender a whole variety of alterations and countless diseases and corruptions.

82c

Timaeus: Furthermore, since secondary structures have been established in the course of nature, a second means of considering diseases arises for someone who wishes to contemplate them. For marrow, bone, flesh and sinew have been compounded from those four constituents, and blood has arisen from them too but in a different way, and the majority of diseases arise from the same causes we just mentioned. However, the most grievous diseases come about when the generation of these substances proceeds in reverse and they then undergo decay. For in the course of nature, flesh and sinew arise from blood, sinew from its fibres because it is akin to these, and flesh from the solidified material that forms when fibre is removed from blood. What's more, the sticky oily material that emerges from the sinews and flesh glues the flesh to the structure of the bones and also nourishes the very bone that surrounds the marrow and makes it grow.

82d

Timaeus: What's more, because of the density of bone, whatever is filtered through it consists of the purest kind of

triangles, and being extremely smooth and oily, it pours drop by drop from the bones and waters the marrow. And when each of these substances comes into being based on these processes, the consequence for the most part is health, but when they are reversed, the result is disease. For whenever flesh is decomposed and releases decomposed matter back into the veins once more, then a lot of variegated blood, mixed with air, adopts multifarious colours and bitterness, as well as acidic and saline properties, and retains all sorts of bile, serum and phlegm. Once these substances have become perverted and corrupted, they first destroy the blood itself, and although they themselves do not provide any nourishment at all to the body, they are borne in all directions through the veins, no longer holding to the natural arrangement of the cycles, at enmity towards themselves because they afford no advantage to themselves, and hostile to any part of the body that stands firm and holds its position. This they destroy and corrupt.

83a

Timaeus: Now, when any extremely old flesh is corrupted, it is difficult to assimilate, is blackened by the prolonged burning process, and being bitter due to the overall corrosion, it most grievously assaults any part of the body that has not yet been corrupted. Yet, on occasion, once the bitter substance has been diluted to some extent, the black-coloured substance takes on acidity rather than bitterness. At other times, when the bitterness has for its part been immersed in blood, it adopts a redder colour, and when the black colour is mixed with this, it goes yellow. And the yellow colour, in turn, mixes with the bitterness whenever the flesh that is decomposed by the flame around the fire is new flesh.

83c

Timaeus: The shared name, bile, has been assigned to all these, presumably by some physicians or even by someone capable of looking at numerous dissimilar entities and discerning among

them a single internal category that deserves to be given a name, while any other forms of bile we mention have a description of their own, based in each case upon their colour. Serum is mild when it is a whey-like product of blood, but aggressive when it comes from black acid bile that is combined with a saline quality by the action of heat, a type called acid phlegm. There is also the decomposition product formed from young tender flesh in the presence of air. This can be filled up with air and enveloped in moisture, producing bubbles in the process. These are not visible individually since they are too small, but they combine together to produce a mass that is visible and has a white colour due to the generation of foam. This entire decomposition process by which soft flesh is compounded with air, we refer to as white phlegm. Of newly formed phlegm there is, in turn, a whey-like part – sweat, tears and any other substances of this sort that flow from the body every day to purify it. And yet these actually become instruments of disease whenever blood is not replenished from food and drink in accordance with nature, but contrary to the natural order, acquires its mass from opposites instead.

83e

Timaeus: Now, when the flesh in the various regions is being assailed by diseases, yet the foundations still remain in place, their affliction is only half as strong, for an easy recovery can still be achieved. However, when the material that binds flesh to bone gets diseased and no longer nourishes the bone, nor acts as a bond between flesh and bone because it is separating off from both of these and from the sinews too,³⁰ and instead of being oily and smooth and sticky it becomes rough and saline, parched by a degenerate lifestyle, then any kind of material that suffers these effects crumbles away beneath the flesh and the sinews, separates from the bones along with the flesh which falls away at its roots, and leaves the sinews exposed and full of brine. The flesh then falls back into the blood-stream making

the diseases we mentioned earlier more intense.

84a

Timaeus: Although these are grievous afflictions of the body, those affecting the more basic parts are even worse. These occur when bone does not breathe in properly because of the density of the flesh, heats up on account of the mouldiness, decays, does not assimilate nutriment but proceeds instead in the opposite direction, and is disintegrated into that nutriment once more. That passes into flesh, and the flesh, falling into the blood-stream, renders all the diseases more severe than those described previously. And the most extreme case of all occurs when the substance of the marrow becomes diseased on account of some deficiency or excess. This brings about the most powerful and formidably fatal diseases, in which the entire nature of the body flows of necessity in the opposite direction.

84c

Timaeus: There is also a third form of these diseases which should be regarded as arising in three ways – from breath, from phlegm or from bile. For whenever the lungs, the dispensers of breaths to the body, are fenced in by some flux or other, the breath, being unable to go in one direction, goes in another direction in greater volume than appropriate. Then the parts that do not receive breath's cooling effect become corrupted, while it proceeds to force itself into the veins, contorts them and dissolves the body, stopping at the barrier at its centre where it gets closed in. These processes cause a huge number of painful diseases, often accompanied by copious sweating. And on occasion, when flesh breaks down within the body, breath is produced but is unable to make its way out, and therefore causes the same travails as the breath that comes from outside. These are at their worst when the breath surrounding the sinews and small veins there swells up, and in the process stretches backwards the tendons and the sinews attached to them. Indeed, it is from the tense condition arising from there

that the diseases have come to be referred to as tetanus and opisthotonos.³¹ These are difficult to cure. In fact, when such diseases arise, fever offers the most relief. The white phlegm is troublesome when confined within because of the air in its bubbles, but it is milder when it finds passage to the outer part of the body, where it produces a variety of colours and white markings and engenders the diseases related thereto. When combined with black bile, it can spread over the orbits that are in the head and throw them into confusion. Now, if this comes to us in sleep it is quite mild. However, if it visits us whilst awake it is harder to get rid of, and being a disease of a sacred substance, it is quite rightly referred to as 'the sacred disease'.³² Phlegm that is acidic and salty is the wellspring of all diseases that produce catarrh, and because the flow takes place from a variety of locations, they have acquired all sorts of names.

85b

Timaeus: Whatever parts of the body are said to be inflamed due to burning and inflammation have all become so on account of bile. Now, if the bile finds an external vent, it boils and sends forth all sorts of growths. However, if it is confined within, it engenders numerous inflammatory diseases. The worst of these occurs when bile is mixed together with pure blood and prevents the blood fibres from exercising their assigned role. For these have been dispersed in the bloodstream so that it may retain a balanced measure of thickness and thinness, and neither flow out through the pores of the body because it is liquefied by the heat, nor on the other hand, have difficulty in circulating through the veins because it is dense and immobile. The fibres by their natural structure preserve a balance of these qualities, but when someone dies and their blood is cooling down, the rest of the blood is liquefied once the fibres coagulate together. However, if the fibres are left as they are, they act in consort with the cool surroundings and quickly congeal the blood. Now, since fibres have this capacity in relation to blood,

when bile, which is a natural product of old blood, dissolves from the flesh back into the blood once more, the warm, moist bile gradually solidifies when it first falls into the blood because of the capacity of the fibres, and as it congeals and is forcibly extinguished it produces cold and shivering within. But when it flows in more voluminously, it boils up, and the heat it possesses overpowers the fibres and shakes them into disorder. And if there is so much bile that it becomes completely dominant, it passes through to the substance of the marrow, immediately undoes the 'ship's cables' of the soul by burning them, and sets it free. If there is less of it and the body resists the process of dissolution, the bile itself is overpowered and is expelled over the entire body surface, or compressed through the veins into the lower or upper abdomen, and is expelled from the body like fugitive elements from a city beset by faction. This produces diarrhoea, dysentery, and a whole range of similar diseases.

86a

Timaeus: When the body is diseased, mainly due to excess fire, continuous high-temperatures and fever are induced; when it is due to excess air, the fevers are quotidian; when due to water they are tertian because water is more sluggish than air or fire; when it is due to earth, the fourth most sluggish of these four, it takes four times as long to purge away and produces quartan fevers that are hard to shake off.

86b

Timaeus: So, the diseases of the body come about in this way, while diseases of the soul, due to the condition of the body, come about in the following way. We must agree that mindlessness is a disease of the soul. However, there are two kinds of mindlessness – madness and stupidity. Therefore, any experience that a person undergoes in which either of these two qualities is involved should be referred to as a disease, and excessive pleasure or pain should be ranked as the most

powerful diseases of the soul. For when a person is elated, or indeed is experiencing the opposite condition because he is in pain, he hastens in an untimely manner to grasp the one and flee from the other, and is unable either to see or to hear aright. He is raving, and in that moment he is least capable of exercising reason. And when the seed associated with the marrow becomes plentiful and free-flowing, and is just like a tree that is fruitful beyond its natural measure, numerous recurrent pangs and just as many pleasures are his lot, born of desires and the consequences thereof. For most of his life he is driven mad by the greatest pleasures and pains; his soul is kept diseased and senseless by the body, yet he gets a reputation for being deliberately degenerate rather than being a sick man. But in truth, lack of sexual restraint is, for the most part, a disease of the soul arising from an abundant and fluid condition of a single substance in the body due to porosity in the bones. And, indeed, almost all those who are unrestrained with respect to pleasure, and are said to be blameworthy because they are willingly bad, are censured unjustly. For no one is willingly bad, rather the bad become bad because of some degenerate condition of the body and the lack of an educated upbringing, both of which are afflictions that come to any person against his will.

87a

Timaeus: Then again, in the case of pain, and based upon the same factors, the soul derives a great deal of its degeneracy from the body. For when acidic or saline phlegm, or any bitter and bilious humours that go wandering about the body, are unable to find a vent to the outside and are trapped inside, they blend their own vapour together with the motion of the soul and get them both mixed up. These engender a whole variety of diseases in the soul, some more intense, some less so, some more extensive, some less so, which are then borne towards the three regions of the soul. Depending upon the region they

assail, they produce multifarious forms of ill-temper and despondency in one case, rashness and cowardice in another, and sometimes a combination of forgetfulness and dullness.

87b

Timaeus: What's more, when men set in such bad ways dwell in cities with bad forms of government, and public and private discourse accords therewith, and yet from childhood upwards they learn nothing to cure these ills, that's how the bad among us become bad, due to these two involuntary factors. For these we should blame the begetters rather than the begotten, and the nurturers rather than those who are nurtured. However, we should be eager in any way we can, through nurture, through activity, and through learning, to flee from badness and embrace its opposite, although these topics obviously belong to discussions of a different sort.

87c

Timaeus: However, it is reasonable and appropriate to present an exposition, the counterpart of these, setting out, in turn, the treatment that will preserve our bodies and our thinking processes in good health. Indeed, it is preferable that our discussion holds to the theme of what is good rather than what is bad. Now, all that is good is beautiful, and beauty is not devoid of measure, so a living being that is to exhibit such qualities must be well proportioned. But when it comes to proportions, we notice the minor ones and take them into account, while the most significant and important never enter our reckoning. Indeed, in the case of health and disease, virtue and vice, no single proportion or disproportion is more important than the relation of soul itself to body itself. In the case of these two, we neither observe nor recognise that whenever a weaker, lesser frame supports a soul that is strong and great in every respect, or, indeed, when the two are conjoined as opposites, the living being, as a whole, is not beautiful because the proportion it lacks is the most important proportion, while the alternative

arrangement is the most beautiful and beloved sight of all to those who are able to behold it.

87e

Timaeus: For instance, a body whose legs are too long, or is out of proportion with itself because of some other excessive tendency, is also inclined to be ugly, prone to much fatigue when it partakes in any exertions, and to a lot of awkwardness and falls, causing a whole range of difficulties to itself because of its abnormal movements. Well, we should also think about the twofold combination that we refer to as a living being in the same way. Indeed, whenever the soul within it is more powerful than the body and becomes passionate, it shakes up the entire body and fills it up with diseases from within, and when it embarks upon some intense study or enquiry it wears out the body. And again, when engaging in teaching and verbal disputation, both in public and in private, it makes the body feverish and troubled due to the strife that is generated and the associated thirst for victory, bringing on rheums and deceiving most so-called physicians into attributing the blame to the wrong cause.

88a

Timaeus: In contrast, whenever a large body that is too strong for the soul is conjoined with a small weak mind, the activities of the stronger dominate and strengthen their own desire. Now, there are two desires naturally associated with human beings – nutriment for our body, and understanding for our most divine part. So, activities of the body make the soul dull, slow to learn and unretentive, and engender within it the worst possible disease, stupidity. Now, there is a single safeguard against these two tendencies – neither to set the soul moving without moving the body, nor body without soul – so that both are protected and become balanced and healthy. Accordingly, a person who engages in mathematics or some other intense study involving the mind should also give the body its due measure of activity

through recourse to gymnastics, while the person who is careful about shaping his body should, in turn, impart a corresponding level of activity to the soul through recourse to music and philosophy in general, if he really intends to be referred to as noble and good in the proper sense.

88d

Timaeus: The parts of the body and soul should also be cared for on the same basis, in imitation of the frame of the Universe. For the body is warmed and cooled internally by whatever enters into it, and, again, is dried out and moistened by whatever is outside it, and suffers any consequences derived from both processes. So whenever someone remains at rest and submits his body to these processes, it is overpowered and destroyed. But if, on the other hand, someone imitates the nurturer and nurse of the Universe, as we call it, he would never allow his body to remain completely still but would move it, and by continually creating certain vibrations in it, maintain a constant, natural balance between the internal and external movements. By this measured shaking, he would order the affections and particles that wander about the body in accordance with their mutual affinity, into a mutual arrangement that reflects the description of the Universe we gave earlier, not allowing enemies to be placed side by side to engender strife and disease in the body, but ensuring the production of health by placing friend alongside friend.

89a

Timaeus: Now, when it comes to movements, the best movement is in oneself, by oneself, for this has most kinship with the movement of thought and of the Universe. Being moved by another is an inferior form of movement, but the worst form involves moving the body, part by part, by means of various agents, while it is lying still. Accordingly, the best way of purging or restoring the body is through gymnastic exercises, second is through the swaying motion of ships and any other

means of carriage that do not induce tiredness. There is a third form of motion, useful in cases of extreme necessity, which should not be accepted under any other circumstances by anyone possessed of intelligence – the use of purgative drugs for medical purposes. For diseases that do not pose a huge threat should not be incited with drugs. Indeed, in a way, the structure of any disease resembles the nature of a living being. In fact, the constitution of these beings involves an assigned span of life applicable to the species as a whole, and each particular creature is born with its own allotted life span, in the absence of the intervention of necessity. For the triangles belonging to each individual are constructed, from the very outset, with the capacity to endure for a certain period of time, and no creature could ever live beyond that limit. Now, the same tendency applies to the constitution of diseases. Whenever someone ignores their allotted time span and destroys them with drugs, minor diseases are inclined to become major, few to become many. Therefore, we should manage everything of this sort through our lifestyle insofar as leisure allows, and not irritate a troublesome malady through the use of drugs.

89d

Timaeus: That's enough said about the living creature as a whole and its bodily parts, and how a person may live in accord with reason, guiding and being guided by himself. But first and most importantly, we must somehow arrange for the part that will guide us to be as beautiful and excellent as possible for its guiding role. Now, to elaborate upon these matters in detail would constitute a task in its own right, yet we would not go much astray if we were to conclude our account by adding a secondary topic in accord with what has gone before, by considering the issue as follows. As we have stated on numerous occasions, there are three forms of soul dwelling in three regions within us, each possessing movements of its own.

Accordingly, we should now declare as briefly as possible, and on the same basis as before, that any form which continues in idleness and keeps quiet its own movements necessarily becomes weaker, while any that are exercised become stronger. Therefore, we should be careful that these movements retain a due proportion with respect to one another.

90a

Timaeus: As for the most lordly form of our soul, we should think of it in this way. It is as a daimon given to each of us by God, and it is said to dwell at the very pinnacle of our bodies to raise us up from Earth to our kindred in Heaven, we who are, properly speaking, a plant not of the Earth but of Heaven. Indeed, it is from there, the place from which soul first had her birth, that the divine agency suspends our head and root, making straight the entire body.

90b

Timaeus: Now, it is inevitable that in someone who is busy with desires and ambitions, and who labours intensely at these, all the opinions he forms are mortal, and insofar as it is possible for a person to become mortal, he takes on its full measure since he has swollen that part of himself. On the other hand, it is completely inevitable, I presume, that someone who has taken seriously to the love of learning and to true understanding, and has exercised these faculties within himself most of all, will think immortal and divine thoughts if he should actually attain truth. Furthermore, insofar as human nature is allowed to partake of immortality, he will obtain its full measure, and since he is constantly caring for the divine, and preserving the particular daimon associated with himself in good order, he will be especially blessed. But, of course, the one and only way of caring for everything is to bestow the nutriment and movement appropriate to each, and in the case of our divine part, the kindred movements are the thoughts and revolutions of the Universe. So, by adhering closely to these, setting aright the

orbits in our head which were corrupted around the time we were born, by coming to an understanding of the harmonies and revolutions of the Universe, each of us should bring our observing part into the likeness of what is observed in accord with the ancient nature, and in that likeness, finally attain the very best life prescribed by the gods for humanity with a view to time present and time future.

90e

Timaeus: And so today's initial assignment, to give a detailed account of the Universe as far as the birth of humanity, almost seems to have reached a conclusion. Of course, we must make brief mention of the manner in which the other living beings, for their part, came into existence, but it is not necessary to lengthen this. For in this way we may think ourselves to be more measured in our discussion of these matters. So let's discuss this as follows. According to the likely account, those who had been born as men and proved cowards, or lived their lives in an unjust manner, were changed in nature to women at their second birth. That's why the god framed the passion of intercourse at that time, fashioning one ensouled living being in us, another in women. Each of the two was made in the following way. They extended the exit passage of drink at the place where it receives the liquid that arrives by the lungs, through the kidneys into the bladder, and expels it along with the air that exerts the pressure. They carried this passage through into the marrow that has been fashioned to run from the head, down the neck and through the spine. Indeed, we said in our previous discussions that this is seed. And since this is ensouled and has a way of getting out at the place we mentioned, it engenders therein a lively desire to flow outwards, and produces the passion of procreation. So, it is that the sexual organ in men has become disobedient and self-willed, like a living creature with no regard for reason who attempts to dominate everything because of its raging desires.

91c

Timaeus: In women, for their part, the so-called matrix or womb is a living being within them, desirous of begetting children. Whenever this has become barren for a long time beyond its due season, it becomes troublesome and discontented. It wanders about the body in all directions, blocks up the exit passages of the breath, and by preventing respiration inflicts extreme distress and brings on a whole variety of other diseases until her desire and the male passion brings them together, and, as if stripping fruit from trees, sows the ploughed land of the womb with living beings, as yet unformed and so small that they are invisible, gives them distinctness once more, nurtures them within to a great size, and thereafter leads them into the light and completes the process of generating living creatures. So this is how women and all that is female came into being.

91d

Timaeus: Birds, as a class, were formed in a different way. Growing feathers rather than hair, they came from men who were harmless but unsubstantial, who studied the upper regions, but believed, due to their simple-mindedness, that the most definitive evidence concerning them comes from sight. The wild land animals, for their part, arose from those who had no recourse to philosophy or any awareness at all of the nature of the Heaven, because they did not make use of the revolutions in the head but followed the lead of the parts of the soul in the region of the chest. So, as a result of living in this way, they extended their forward limbs and their heads to the earth due to their kinship therewith, and settled there, having acquired elongated heads of all varieties, corresponding to the way in which their own revolutions had been pressed together on account of idleness. So that is the reason why this type of creature developed as four-footed or many footed; God placed more supports under those who were more mindless so that

they would be more drawn to the earth. The most mindless among them, in whom the entire body is stretched out upon the earth, no longer needed feet, so the gods made them without feet, to crawl in the dust of the earth. The fourth type arose in water from the completely unintelligent and unlearned. Those who fashioned them, deeming them no longer worthy to breathe pure air because they had an impure soul due to all-pervasive error, forced them to breathe the murky depths of water rather than fine, pure air. Hence, the race of fishes, of shellfish, and all the creatures that have come into being in water, have been assigned an extreme dwelling place as a penalty for their extreme stupidity.

92c

Timaeus: And it is on the basis of these principles that all living creatures, then and now, are transformed into one another; they are changed through the acquisition or loss of nous or stupidity. So, we may now declare that our discourse concerning the Universe has at last come to an end. This Universe has received mortal and immortal living beings and has been filled with them, and, accordingly, has become a visible, living being encompassing all that is visible, an image of whatever is known by nous, a perceptible god, supreme, excellent, sublime and perfect, this Heaven, only begotten and one.

NOTES

1. The gathering 'yesterday' was apparently that described in the Republic. There is much speculation as to the identity of the fourth, missing interlocutor.
2. Solon was the most famous early Athenian lawgiver, whose constitutional reforms in the 6th century brought an end to the great strife in the city.
3. The goddess in question is Athena. The reference to her festival is an indication that the discussion is taking place during the Panathenaea, which was held every year in Athens in honour of the patron goddess.
4. Apaturia were festivals held annually around the Greek world. In Athens, the Panathenaea was an opportunity for the Attic clans to meet to discuss various issues.
5. Deucalion and his wife Pyrrha were reputed to have been the only survivors of a cataclysmic flood sent by Zeus.
6. This is a reference to the Straits of Gibraltar.
7. (a) 2:4 :: 4:8 and (b) 8:4 :: 4:2, so (c) 4:8 :: 2:4. In (a) they are first/middle/last. In (b) the last has become first and the first last. In (c) the middle has become first and last and the last and first both middle. Hence, any of the three can become first, last or middle and so in that sense they are the same.
8. F:A :: A:W / A:W :: W:E, so there are now two middle terms, air and water in this example.
9. The circular motion by revolving on its own axis is assigned to the all. It alone involves no movement away from a fixed position and is thus termed 'un-wandering'.
10. The three mixtures are intermediate types of being, same and other, each formed by mixing their indivisible kinds with their divisible kinds.
11. The first mean is a harmonic mean, e.g. between 6 and 12 it is 8, which is $\frac{1}{3}$ greater than 6 and $\frac{1}{3}$ less than 12. The second mean is an arithmetic mean, e.g. in the case of 6 and 12 it is 9, which exceeds 6 by 3 and is 3 less than 12.
12. The Greek word for planets means wanderers, and refers to their irregular motion as compared to the 'fixed' stars.
13. This is a reference to the dawn-bearer (Venus).
14. This is Mercury.

15. Hence, the stars/gods rotate on their own axes and are also carried uniformly across the sky. These are the two assigned motions, the latter of which can be observed in the night sky.
16. The seven motions are rotation on an axis, movement to the right, left, up, down, forward and backward. Only the first two are exhibited by the stars/gods.
17. A connection is implied here between the Greek word for 'sensations' (aisthêseis) and the word for 'shaking' (aïssein).
18. This is a very close paraphrase of Euripides' *Phoenician Women*, 1762.
19. This sentence is evidence for equating nous with the Demiurge. The phrase 'with few exceptions' probably refers to the section on the mechanism of vision (45b–c).
20. Omitting *pur* at 49d6, following Cornford.
21. The former is the right-angled isosceles triangle. The latter is the right-angled scalene triangle.
22. This simply means that the three 60° angles that meet at the corner of a tetrahedron add up to 180°, which is not an obtuse angle but next after the most obtuse angle.
23. This refers to a tetrahedron inscribed within a sphere.
24. That is, a square.
25. This refers to the dodecahedron, which is the closest of all the solids to the spherical shape of the universe.
26. The reference here seems to be to a supposed connection between the Greek words for 'heat' and for 'cutting into pieces'.
27. The Greek word for brain translates literally as 'in the head'.
28. This is the brain itself.
29. The Greek word for living things, *zoa*, is often applied to animals. The point here is that plants, given that they are living things, have just as much right as animals to be called *zoa*.
30. The text is corrupt here. This translation follows Waterfield and Zeyl.
31. *Opisthotonos* is a spasm of the muscles around the neck and back often caused by severe tetanus, a bacterial disease that causes muscle rigidity.
32. Epilepsy was referred to as the sacred disease.

Hipparchus

ΙΠΠΑΡΧΟΣ

Plato

translated by W.R.M. Lamb

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Socrates: And what is love of gain? What can it be, and who are the lovers of gain?

Friend: In my opinion, they are those who think it worth while to make gain out of things of no worth.

Socrates: Is it your opinion that they know those things to be of no worth, or do not know? For if they do not know, you mean that the lovers of gain are fools.

Friend: No, I do not mean they are fools, but rascals who wickedly yield to gain, because they know that the things out of which they dare to make their gain are worthless, [225b] and yet they dare to be lovers of gain from mere shamelessness.

Socrates: Well now, do you mean by the lover of gain such a man, for instance, as a farmer who plants something which he knows is a worthless herb, and thinks fit to make gain out of it when he has reared it up? Is that the sort of man you mean?

Friend: The lover of gain, as such, Socrates, thinks he ought to make gain from everything.

Socrates: Please do not speak so recklessly, as though you had been wronged by someone, but give me your attention and answer just as you would if I were beginning my questions over again. Do you not admit that the lover of gain has knowledge of the worth of the thing from which he thinks it worth while to make gain?

Friend: I do.

Socrates: Then who has knowledge of the worth of plants, and of the sort of season and soil in which they are worth planting — if we too may throw in one of those artful phrases which adroit pleaders use to trick out their speeches in the law courts? [225d]

Friend: For my part, I should say a farmer.

Socrates: And by “think it worth while to make gain” do you mean aught but “thinking one ought to make gain”?

Friend: I mean that.

Socrates: Then do not attempt to deceive me, who am now quite an elderly person, [226a] and you so young, by making, as you did just now, an answer that is not even your own thought; but tell me in all truth, do you suppose that any man who was taking up farming and who knew it was a worthless plant that he was planting, could think to make gain from it?

Friend: Upon my word, I do not.

Socrates: Or again, take a horseman who knows that he is providing worthless food for his horse; do you suppose he is unaware that he is destroying his horse?

Friend: I do not. [226b]

Socrates: So he does not think to make gain from that worthless food.

Friend: No.

Socrates: Or again, take a navigator who has furnished his ship with worthless spars and ropes; do you think he is unaware that he will suffer for it, and will be in danger of being lost himself, and of losing the ship and all her cargo?

Friend: I do not.

Socrates: So he does not think to make gain from [226c] that worthless tackle?

Friend: No, indeed.

Socrates: But does a general, who knows that his army has worthless arms, think to make gain, or think it worth while to make gain, from them?

Friend: By no means.

Socrates: Or does a flute-player who has worthless flutes, or a harper with a lyre, a bowman with a bow, or anyone else at all, in short, among ordinary craftsmen or sensible men in general, with any implement or other equipment of any sort that is worthless, think to make gain from it? [226d]

Friend: To all appearance, no.

Socrates: Then whoever can they be, your lovers of gain? For I presume they are not the people whom we have successively mentioned, but people who know their worthless things, and yet think they are to make gain from them. But in that case, by what you say, remarkable sir, no man alive is a lover of gain

Friend: Well, Socrates, I should like to call those lovers of gain who from insatiable greed consumedly long for things that are even quite petty and of little or no worth, [226e] and so love gain, in each case.

Socrates: Not knowing, of course, my excellent friend, that the things are worthless; for we have already convinced ourselves by our argument that this is impossible.

Friend: I agree.

Socrates: And if not knowing this, clearly they are ignorant of it, but think that those worthless things are worth a great deal.

Friend: Apparently.

Socrates: Now, of course lovers of gain must love gain?

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: And by gain you mean the opposite of loss? [227a]

Friend: I do.

Socrates: And is it a good thing for anyone to suffer loss?

Friend: For no one.

Socrates: Rather an evil?

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: So mankind are harmed by loss.

Friend: They are harmed.

Socrates: Then loss is an evil.

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: And gain is the opposite of loss.

Friend: The opposite.

Socrates: So that gain is a good.

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: Hence it is those who love the good that you call lovers of gain.

Friend: So it seems. [227b]

Socrates: At least there is nothing mad, my friend, about lovers of gain, as you describe them. But tell me, do you yourself love, or not love, whatever is good?

Friend: I love it.

Socrates: And is there anything good that you do not love, or must it then be evil?

Friend: Upon my word, nothing.

Socrates: In fact, I expect you love all good things.

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: Well now, ask me on my side whether I do not likewise: for I shall agree with you, for my part, that I love good things. But besides you and me, do you not think that all the rest of mankind [227c] love good things, and hate evil things?

Friend: It appears so to me.

Socrates: And we admitted that gain is good?

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: On this new showing, everyone appears to be a lover of gain; whereas, by our former way of arguing, no one was a lover of gain. So on which of the two arguments are we to rely, in order to avoid error?

Friend: What has to be done, I think, Socrates, is to conceive the lover of gain rightly. The right view of the lover of gain is that he is one who concerns himself with, [227d] and thinks fit to make gain from, things from which honest men do not dare to make gain.

Socrates: But you see, my sweet sir, we have just admitted that making gain is being benefited.

Friend: Well, what of that?

Socrates: There is the further point we have admitted in addition to this — that all men wish for good things always.

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: Then good men likewise wish to have all gains, if these are good things. [227e]

Friend: Not those gains from which they are bound, Socrates, to suffer harm.

Socrates: By “suffer harm” do you mean “suffer loss,” or something else?

Friend: No, I mean just “suffer loss.”

Socrates: Well, do men suffer loss from gain or from loss?

Friend: From both; for they suffer loss from loss and from wicked gain.

Socrates: Pray now, do you consider that any useful and good thing is wicked?

Friend: I do not. [228a]

Socrates: And we admitted a little while ago that gain is the opposite of loss, which is an evil.

Friend: I agree.

Socrates: And that, being the opposite of an evil, it is good?

Friend: That was our admission.

Socrates: So you see, you are attempting to deceive me, for you deliberately contradict what we agreed to just now.

Friend: No, on my honor, Socrates; on the contrary, it is you who are deceiving me, by twisting this way and that so perplexingly in your talk. [228b]

Socrates: Hush, hush! Why, surely it would be wrong of me not to obey a good and wise person.

Friend: Who is that? And to what are you referring now?

Socrates: I mean my and your fellow-citizen, Pisistratus's son Hipparchus, of Philaidae, who was the eldest and wisest of Pisistratus's sons, and who, among the many goodly proofs of wisdom that he showed, first brought the poems of Homer into this country of ours, and compelled the rhapsodes at the Panathenaea to recite them in relay, one man following on another, as [228c] they still do now. He dispatched a fifty-oared galley for Anacreon of Teos, and brought him into our city. Simonides of Ceos he always had about him, prevailing on him by plenteous fees and gifts. All this he did from a wish to educate the citizens, in order that he might have subjects of the highest excellence; for he thought it not right to grudge wisdom to any, so noble and good was he. And when his people in the city had been educated and were

admiring him for his wisdom, [228d] he proceeded next, with the design of educating those of the countryside, to set up figures of Hermes for them along the roads in the midst of the city and every district town; and then, after selecting from his own wise lore, both learnt from others and discovered for himself, the things that he considered the wisest, he threw these into elegiac form and inscribed them on the figures as verses of his own and testimonies of his wisdom, so that in the first place [228e] his people should not admire those wise Delphic legends of ““Know thyself”” and ““Nothing overmuch””, and the other sayings of the sort, but should rather regard as wise the utterances of Hipparchus; and that in the second place, through passing up and down and reading his words and acquiring a taste for his wisdom, they might resort hither from the country for the completion of their education. There are two such inscriptions of his: on the left side [229a] of each Hermes there is one in which the god says that he stands in the midst of the city or the township, while on the right side he says:”The memorial of Hipparchus: walk with just intent.

“There are many other fine inscriptions from his poems on other figures of Hermes, and this one in particular, on the Steiria road, in which he says: [229b] “The memorial of Hipparchus: deceive not a friend.

“I therefore should never dare, I am sure, to deceive you, who are my friend, or disobey the great Hipparchus, after whose death the Athenians were for three years under the despotic rule of his brother Hippias, and you might have heard anyone of the earlier period say that it was only in these years that there was despotism in Athens, and that at all other times the Athenians lived very much as in the reign of Cronos. And the subtler sort of people say [229c] that Hipparchus’s death was due, not to the cause supposed by most — the disqualification of the assassin’s sister from bearing the basket, for that is a

silly motive — but because Harmodius had become the favorite of Aristogeiton and had been educated by him. Thus Aristogeiton also prided himself on educating people, and he regarded Hipparchus as a dangerous rival. And at that time, it is said, Harmodius [229d] happened to be himself in love with one of the handsome and well-born youths of the day; they do tell his name, but I cannot remember it. Well, for a while this youth admired both Harmodius and Aristogeiton as wise men, but afterwards, when he associated with Hipparchus, he despised them, and they were so overcome with the pain of this “disqualification” that they slew Hipparchus.

Friend: It would seem, then, Socrates, either that you do not regard me as your friend, or if you do, that you do not obey Hipparchus. [229e] For that you are not deceiving me — though I cannot tell how you contrive it — in your talk, is more than I can believe.

Socrates: Well now, as though we were playing draughts, I am willing to let you revoke, as you please, anything you have said in carrying on the discussion, in order that you may not think you are being deceived. So tell me, shall I revoke for you the statement that all men desire good things?

Friend: No, thank you.

Socrates: Well, that suffering loss, or loss, is an evil?

Friend: No, thank you.

Socrates: Well, that gain, or making gain, is the opposite of loss, or suffering loss? [230a]

Friend: Nor that either.

Socrates: Well, that making gain, as the opposite of evil, is a good?

Friend: Nothing of all this do I bid you revoke for me.

Socrates: You think, then, it seems, that some gain is good, and some evil.

Friend: I do.

Socrates: Well then, I revoke so much for you; so let us assume that some gain is good, and some other gain evil. But the good sort is no more gain than the evil sort, is it?

Friend: What do you mean by this question?

Socrates: I will explain. Is there both good and evil food? [230b]

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: And is the one sort more food than the other, or are they both similarly this same thing, food, and in this respect does the one differ no wise from the other, in being food, but only in the fact of the one being good and the other evil?

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: And so with drink and every other class of things that exist, when some things in any class come to be good, and others evil, one thing does not differ from another in that respect whereby they are the same? For instance, [230c] one man, I suppose, is virtuous, and another wicked.

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: But neither of them, I conceive, is more or less man than the other — neither the virtuous than the wicked, nor the wicked than the virtuous.

Friend: What you say is true.

Socrates: Then are we to take the same view of gain also, that both the wicked and the virtuous sort are similarly gain?

Friend: Necessarily.

Socrates: So he who has virtuous gain is no whit the more a gainer than he who has wicked gain: neither sort [230d] is found to be more gain, as we agree.

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: For neither of them has addition of either more or less.

Friend: No, indeed.

Socrates: And how could one do or suffer anything more or less with a thing of this sort, that had neither of these additions?

Friend: Impossible.

Socrates: Since, therefore, both of these are gains and gain-making affairs, we must now consider what it can be that leads you to call both of them gain: [230e] what is it that you see to be the same in both? Suppose you were to ask me, in those instances that I gave just now, what it is that leads me to call both good food and evil food alike food, I should tell you — for this reason, because both are a dry sustenance of the body. For that, I am sure you would agree, is what food is, would you not?

Friend: I would.

Socrates: And so too about drink the answer would be on the same lines, that the wet sustenance of the body, [231a] whether it be wholesome or pernicious, has this name of drink; and likewise with the rest. Try therefore on your part to imitate my method of answering. When you say that virtuous gain and wicked gain are both gain, what is it that you see to be the same in them, judging it to be the actual element of gain? And if again you are yourself unable to answer, just let me put it for your consideration, whether you describe as gain every acquisition that one has acquired either with no expense, or as a profit over and above one's expense. [231b]

Friend: I believe that is what I call gain.

Socrates: Do you include a case where, after enjoying a banquet at which one has had much good cheer without any expense, one acquires an illness?

Friend: Upon my word, not I.

Socrates: And if one acquired health from attending a banquet, would one acquire gain or loss?

Friend: Gain.

Socrates: Hence gain is not just acquiring any acquisition.

Friend: No, indeed.

Socrates: Do you mean, not if it is evil? Or will one acquire no gain even if one acquires something good?

Friend: Apparently one will, if it is good. [231c]

Socrates: And if it is evil, will not one acquire loss?

Friend: I think so.

Socrates: You see, then, how you are running round again to the same old point? Gain is found to be good, and loss evil.

Friend: For my part, I cannot tell what to say.

Socrates: And not without good reason, sir. Now answer this further question: you say that if one acquires more than the amount one has spent, it is gain?

Friend: I do not mean, when it is evil, but if one gets more gold or silver than one has spent.

Socrates: Now, I am just going to ask you about that. Tell me, [231d] if one spends half a pound of gold and gets double that weight in silver, has one got gain or loss?

Friend: Loss, I presume, Socrates for one's gold is reduced to twice, instead of twelve times, the value of silver.

Socrates: But you see, one has got more; or is double not more than half?

Friend: Not in worth, the one being silver and the other gold.

Socrates: So gain, it seems, must have this addition of worth. At least, you now say that silver, though more than gold, is not worth as much, and that gold, though less, is of equal worth. [231e]

Friend: Assuredly, for that is the case.

Socrates: Then the valuable is what produces gain, whether it be small or great, and the valueless produces no gain.

Friend: Yes.

Socrates: And by the valuable you mean simply, valuable to possess?

Friend: Yes, to possess.

Socrates: And again, by what is valuable to possess, do you mean the unprofitable or the profitable?

Friend: The profitable, I presume.

Socrates: And the profitable is good?

Friend: Yes. [232a]

Socrates: And so, most valiant of men, have we not here once more, for the third or fourth time, the admission that what produces gain is good?

Friend: So it seems.

Socrates: Then do you remember the point from which this discussion of ours arose?

Friend: I think I do.

Socrates: In case you do not, I will remind you. You maintained against me that good men do not wish to make all sorts of gain, but only those gains that are good, and not those that are wicked.

Friend: Yes. [232b]

Socrates: And now the argument has compelled us to acknowledge that all gains, both small and great, are good?

Friend: Yes, it has compelled me, at least, Socrates, rather than persuaded me.

Socrates: Well, later on, perhaps, it might also persuade you. Now, however, whether you are persuaded or whatever is your feeling, you at least agree with me that all gains are good, both small and great ones.

Friend: Yes, I do admit it.

Socrates: And you admit that virtuous men all wish for all good things, do you not?

Friend: I do. [232c]

Socrates: But, you know, you stated yourself that wicked men love both small and great gains.

Friend: I did.

Socrates: And so, by your account, all men will be lovers of gain, whether they be virtuous or wicked.

Friend: Apparently.

Socrates: Hence it is not right to reproach anybody with being a lover of gain: for he who makes this reproach is actually such an one himself.

The Rival Lovers

ΕΡΑΣΤΑΙ

Plato

translated by W.R.M. Lamb

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THE RIVAL LOVERS.

SOCRATES I entered the grammar school of the teacher Dionysius, and saw there the young men who are accounted the most comely in form and of distinguished family, and their lovers. Now it chanced that two of the young people were disputing, but about what, I did not clearly overhear: it appeared, however, that they were disputing either about Anaxagoras or about Oenopides; at any rate, they appeared to be drawing circles, [132b] and they were imitating certain inclinations with their arms, bending to it and taking it most earnestly. Then I — for I was sitting beside the lover of one of the pair — nudged him with my elbow and asked him what on earth the two youngsters were so earnest about, and I said: Is it then something great and fine, in which they are so earnestly immersed?

Great and fine, indeed! he replied: why, these fellows are prating about the heavenly bodies, and babbling philosophy. [132c] Then I, surprised at his answer, said: Young man, do you consider philosophizing to be shameful? Else, why do you speak so sharply?

Then the other youth — for he chanced to be sitting near him, as his rival in love — when he heard my question and his rival's answer, said: You do yourself no good, Socrates, by pressing this fellow with a further question, as to whether he considers philosophizing to be shameful. Do you not know that he has spent the whole of his life in practising the neckhold, and stuffing himself, and sleeping? So why did you suppose he would make any other reply than that philosophy is shameful? [132d] Now this one of the two lovers had spent his time on humane studies, whereas the other, whom he was abusing, had spent his on athletics. So I decided that I had best relinquish the other, whom I had been questioning, since he did not even

himself set up to be experienced in words, but only in deeds; and that I should interrogate the one who set up to be wiser, in order that so far as I was able I might get some benefit from him. I said therefore: I addressed my question to both in common; but if you think you could answer more creditably than he, I put the same question to you as I did to him: do you consider philosophizing to be honorable or not? [133a] Then the two striplings, overhearing us speak somewhat like this, were silent, and ceasing from their own contention they became listeners to ours. What their lovers' sensations were, I do not know, but I myself, at any rate, was staggered; for every time I am staggered by handsome young people. It seemed to me, however, that my young friend too was in as great a flutter as myself; but nevertheless he answered me in a most ambitious spirit: Why, of course, Socrates, he said, if I should ever consider philosophizing to be shameful, I should not account myself so much as a man, [133b] nor anyone else either who was disposed to think so. Here he pointed to his rival lover, and spoke with a loud voice, in order that his favorite might hear every word.

Then I remarked: So philosophizing seems to you to be honorable?

Quite so, he said.

Well now, I said; does it seem to you possible to know whether anything is honorable or shameful without knowing what it is fundamentally?

No, he said. [133c] Then do you know, I went on, what philosophizing is?

Certainly I do, said he.

Then what is it? I asked.

Why, just what Solon called it; you know it was Solon who said: "And ever, as I older grow, I learn yet more and more;

“Solon Fr. 18 — and I agree with him that a man who intends to philosophize should in this way be ever learning something or other, whether he be younger or older, in order that he may learn as many things as possible in his life. Now at first I felt there was something in his reply, but then, on second thoughts, I asked him whether he considered philosophy to be much learning. [133d] To which he answered: Certainly.

And do you consider philosophy to be merely honorable, I asked, or good as well?

Good as well, he said: very much so.

Then do you observe this as peculiar to philosophy, or do you find it similarly in everything else? For example, do you consider the love of athletics to be not merely honorable, but good as well, or do you not?

Whereupon he, most slyly, gave a double answer: To him my statement must be “neither” ; but to you, Socrates, I acknowledge it to be both honorable and good: [133e] for I consider this the right view.

Then I asked him: Well now, in athletics, do you consider that much exercise is love of athletics?

To which he replied: Certainly, just as in philosophizing I consider much learning to be philosophy.

Then I said: And do you then consider that the lovers of athletics desire anything else than that which will cause them to be in good bodily condition?

Only that, he replied.

And does much exercise, I asked, cause them to be in good bodily condition? [134a] Yes, for how, he replied, could one be

in good bodily condition through little exercise?

Here I felt it was time to stir up the lover of athletics, in order that he might give me the support of his athletic experience; so I proceeded to ask him: And you then, pray, why are you silent, excellent sir, while your friend here is speaking thus? Do you agree that men are in good bodily condition through much exercise, or is it rather through moderate exercise?

For my part, Socrates, he said, I thought even a pig — [134b] as the saying is — would have known that moderate exercise causes them to be in good bodily condition, so why should not a fellow who is sleepless and unfed, with unchafed neck and slender, care-worn frame! And when he had said this the boys were delighted and laughed their approval, while the other lover blushed.

Then I said to him: Well, do you now concede that it is neither much, nor little, but moderate exercise that causes men to be in good bodily condition? Or do you bid defiance to the two of us on this point? [134c] To which he answered: Against him I should be only too glad to fight it out, and I am certain I should prove able to support the theory I have put forward, even had I put forward a weaker one; for he is naught. But with you I do not aim at winning an unscrupulous success; and so I admit that not a great but a moderate amount of athletics causes good condition in men.

And what of food? Moderate or much? I asked.

The same applied to food, he admitted. [134d] Then I went on and tried to compel him also to admit that everything else connected with the body when most beneficial, was the moderate thing, not the much or the little; and he admitted that it was the moderate thing.

And now, I said, as regards the soul; are moderate or immoderate things beneficial, as adjuncts of it?

Moderate things, he replied.

And are studies among the adjuncts of the soul?

He admitted they were.

So among these also it is the moderate that are beneficial, and not the much?

He agreed.

Then whom should we be justified in asking what sort of exercise or food is moderate for the body?

The three of us agreed that it must be a doctor or a trainer. [134e] And whom should we ask about the moderate measure in the sowing of seed?

In that matter, we agreed, it must be a farmer.

And whom should we be justified in asking as to the moderate degree and kind, in regard to the sowing and planting of studies in the soul?

At this point we all began to be full of perplexity; [135a] then I, mocking at them, asked: Do you mind, since we are in perplexity, if we ask these boys here? or perhaps we are ashamed, as Homer said the suitors were, and do not think it fit there should be someone else who will string the bow?

Then, as it seemed to me that they were losing their zeal for the argument, I tried to pursue the inquiry in another way, and said: But what, as nearly as we can guess, are the kinds of learning which the philosopher should learn, since he is not to learn all things or many things? [135b] At this the wiser one interjected: The finest and most suitable kinds of learning are those which will bring him the most reputation for philosophy;

and he will get most reputation if he appears well versed in all the arts, or if not in all, in as many of them, and those the most considerable, as he can, by learning so much of them as befits a free man to learn, that is, what belongs to the understanding rather than the handiwork of each.

Well now, do you mean, I asked, in the same way as in carpentry? For there, you know, you can buy a carpenter for five [135c] or six minae, but a first-rate architect cannot be got for even ten thousand drachmae; few such, indeed, could be found throughout the whole of Greece. Is it something of this sort that you mean? When he heard me say this, he admitted that something like this was what he himself meant.

I next asked him if it was not impossible for the same person to learn in this way merely two of the arts, not to speak of many or the principal ones; to which he replied: Do not conceive me, Socrates, [135d] to be stating that the philosopher must have accurate knowledge of each of the arts, like the actual adept in any of them; I mean only so far as may be expected of a free and educated man: that is, he should be able to follow the explanations of the craftsman more readily than the rest of the company, and to contribute an opinion of his own which will make him appear the cleverest and most accomplished of the company who may at any time be present at some verbal or practical exposition of the arts.

Then, as I was still unsettled in my mind as to the drift of his words, I asked him: Do I quite grasp the sort of man whom you mean by the philosopher? [135e] For you seem to me to mean someone like the all-round athletes in contest with the runners or the wrestlers: the former yield, you know, to the latter in their particular exercises, and are their inferiors in these, but are superior to the usual sort of athletes and beat them. I daresay it may be something of this sort that you would suggest as the effect produced by philosophy on those who make it their

pursuit: they yield to those who are first-rate [136a] in an understanding of the arts, but in taking the second place they surpass the rest; and in this way the man who has studied philosophy comes just next to the top in everything. That is the kind of person whom you appear to me to indicate.

You are quite right, it seems to me, Socrates, he said, in your conception of the philosopher's position, with your comparison of him to the all-round athlete. For it is precisely his nature not to be enslaved to any business, or to work out anything exactly, so as to let his application to that one matter make him deficient in the rest, [136b] as the craftsmen do, but to have a moderate contact with all of them.

Well, after this answer I was eager to know clearly what he meant, so I inquired of him whether he conceived of good men as useful or useless.

Useful, I should say, Socrates, he replied.

Then if good men are useful, are wicked men useless?

He agreed that they were.

Again, do you consider that philosophers are useful persons or not? [136c] He agreed that they were useful; nay, more, that he considered they were most useful of all.

Come now, let us make out, if what you say is true, where these second-best men are also useful to us: for clearly the philosopher is inferior to any particular adept in the arts.

He agreed.

Well now, I went on, if you yourself, or one of your friends for whom you feel great concern, should have fallen sick, would you fetch that second-best man into the house with a view to obtaining health, or would you summon a doctor? [136d] For my part, I should have both, he replied.

Please do not say “both,” I said, but which of the two you would prefer and also summon first.

No one, he replied, would make any question but that the doctor should be preferred and also summoned first.

And again, if you were in a ship that was making rough weather, to which would you rather entrust yourself and yours, the pilot or the philosopher?

I should choose the pilot.

And so it will be in everything else: so long as there is some craftsman, the philosopher will not be useful?

Apparently, he replied. [136e] So now we find that the philosopher is a useless person? For I suppose we always have craftsmen; and we have agreed that good men are useful, and bad ones useless.

He was obliged to agree to this.

Then what follows? Am I to ask you, or will it be too ill-mannered?

Ask whatever you please.

Well, my aim, I said, is merely to recall our agreements upon [137a] what has been stated. The matter stands somewhat like this. We agreed that philosophy is an honorable thing, and that philosophers are good; and that good men are useful, and wicked men useless: but then again we agreed that philosophers, so long as we have craftsmen, are useless, and that we always do have craftsmen. Has not all this been agreed?

Yes, to be sure, he replied.

Then we agreed, it seems, by your account — if philosophizing means having knowledge of the arts in the way you describe — that philosophers are wicked and useless so long as there are

arts [137b] among mankind. But I expect they are not so really, my friend, and that philosophizing is not just having a concernment in the arts or spending one's life in meddlesome stooping and prying and accumulation of learning, but something else; because I imagined that this life was actually a disgrace, and that people who concerned themselves with the arts were called sordid. But we shall know more definitely whether this statement of mine is true, if you will answer me this: What men know how to punish horses rightly? [137c] Is it those who make them into the best horses, or some other men?

Those who make them into the best horses.

Or again, is it not the men who know how to make dogs into the best dogs that know also how to punish them rightly?

Yes.

Then it is the same art that makes them into the best dogs and punishes them rightly?

It appears so to me, he replied.

Again, is the art that makes them into the best ones and punishes them rightly the same as that which knows the good and the bad ones, or is it some other?

The same, he said.

Then in the case of men also will you be prepared to agree that the art [137d] which makes them into the best men is that which punishes them rightly and distinguishes the good and the bad ones?

Certainly, he said.

And that which does this to one, does it also to many, and that which does it to many, does it also to one?

Yes.

And so it is also with horses and everything else?

I agree.

Then what is the knowledge which rightly punishes the licentious and law-breaking people in our cities? Is it not judicature?

Yes.

And is it any other art than this that you call justice?

No, only this. [137e] And that whereby they punish rightly is that whereby they know the good and bad people?

It is.

And whoever knows one will know many also?

Yes.

And whoever does not know many will not know one?

I agree.

Then if one were a horse, and did not know the good and wicked horses, would one not know which sort one was oneself?

I think not.

And if one were an ox and did not know the wicked and good oxen, would one not know which sort one was oneself?

That is so, he said.

And so it would be, if one were a dog?

He agreed. [138a] Well now, when one is a man, and does not know the good and bad men, one surely cannot know whether one is good or wicked oneself, since one is a man also oneself?

He granted this.

And is “not knowing oneself” being temperate, or not being temperate?

Not being temperate.

So “knowing oneself” is being temperate?

I agree, he said.

So this is the message, it seems, of the Delphic inscription — that one is to practise temperance and justice.

It seems so.

And it is by this same art that we know also how to punish rightly?

Yes.

Then that whereby we know how to punish rightly [138b] is justice, and that whereby we know how to distinguish our own and others’ quality is temperance?

It seems so, he said.

Then justice and temperance are the same thing?

Apparently.

And further, it is thus, you know, that cities are well ordered — when the wrongdoers pay the penalty.

That is true, he said.

Hence this is also statecraft.

He concurred.

Again, when one man governs a city rightly, is he not called a despot and king?

I agree.

And he governs by a kingly and despotic art?

That is so.

And these arts are the same as the former?

Apparently. [138c] Again, when a man singly governs a house aright, what is he called? Is he not a house-manager and master?

Yes.

Then would he also govern his house well by justice, or by some other art?

By justice.

Hence they are all the same, it seems, — king, despot, statesman, house-manager, master, and the temperate man and the just man; and it is all one art, — the kingly, the despotic, the statesman's, the master's, the house-manager's, and justice and temperance.

It is so, apparently, he said. [138d] Then, if it is disgraceful in the philosopher to be unable, when a doctor speaks about the sick, either to follow his remarks or to contribute anything of his own to what is being said or done, and to be in the same case when any other of the craftsmen speaks, is it not disgraceful that he should be unable, when it is a judge or a king or some other of the persons whom we have just instanced, either to follow their words or contribute anything to their business?

It must indeed be disgraceful, Socrates, to have nothing to contribute to subjects of such great importance! [138e] Are we then to say, I asked, that in these matters also he is to be an all-round athlete, a second-rate man, taking the second place in all the subjects of this art — he, the philosopher — and is to be useless so long as there is one of these persons; or that, first of all, he is to entrust his own house to nobody else and is not to take the second place in it, but is himself to judge and punish rightly, if his house is to be well managed?

He granted me that it must be so.

Secondly, I presume, whether his friends entrust him with an arbitration, or the state charges him to determine [139a] or judge any matter, it is disgraceful for him, my good friend, in such cases, to be found in the second or third place, and not to lead?

I agree.

Hence we see, my excellent sir, that philosophizing is very far from being much learning and that affair of busying oneself with the arts.

On my saying this the cultivated youth was silent, feeling ashamed for what he had said before, while the unlearned one said it was as I stated; and the rest of the company praised the argument.

Theages

ΘΕΑΓΗΣ

Plato

translated by W.R.M. Lamb

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Demodocus: Socrates, I was wanting to have some private talk with you, if you had time to spare; even if there is some demand, which is not particularly important, on your time, do spare some, nevertheless, for me.

Socrates: Why, in any case I happen to have time to spare, and for you, moreover, I have plenty. Well, you are free to say whatever you wish.

Demodocus: Then do you mind if we step aside here from the street into the portico of Zeus the Liberator?

Socrates: As you think best. [121b]

Demodocus: Let us go, then. Socrates, it would seem that all growths follow the same course, both those that grow from the earth, and the animals, including man. In regard to the plants, as you know, we who cultivate the earth find it the easiest part of our work to make all our preparations that are needed before planting, and to do the planting itself; but when the plant begins to grow, thenceforward we have a great deal of difficult and vexatious business in tending the new growth. [121c] Such, it seems, is also the case in regard to men: I take my own concerns as evidence for judging of the rest. For indeed I have found the planting, or the procreation — whichever one ought to call it — of this son of mine the easiest thing in the world; but his upbringing has been vexatious and a constant source of alarm, so great are my fears for him. Among the many instances that I could mention, the desire which occupies him at the moment is a thing that especially alarms me: for it is not an ill-bred desire, but a dangerous one, since here we have him, Socrates, as he says, desiring to become wise. [121d] My opinion is that some of his fellow-townsmen, about his own age, who pay visits to the city, excite him with accounts of certain discussions they have heard there; and in his envy of these he has long been pestering me with the demand that I should take

due thought for his needs, and pay fees to some sophist or other who will make him wise. Now I do not mind so much about the fees, but I believe he is running into no slight danger [122a] where he is hastening. I did for a time restrain him with good advice; but since I am no longer able to do so, I believe my best course is to comply with his request, in order that he may not resort, perchance, behind my back to somebody who will corrupt him. So I have come now on this very business of placing this youth with one of these sophists, or purveyors of wisdom, as they are held to be. It is a happy chance, therefore, that has thrown you in our way, as I should be particularly glad, with this plan of action in my mind, to ask your advice. Come, if you have any advice to give [122b] on what you have heard from me, you not only may, but should, give it.

Socrates: Well, you know, Demodocus, they do say that advice is a holy thing. And so, if ever it is to be accounted holy, it must be in this instance, in which you now seek it. For there is no more divine matter on which a mortal could take counsel than the education either [122c] of himself or of his relations. Now, first of all, let you and me come to an agreement as to what we suppose that this thing can be, on which we are taking counsel; for it may happen that I conceive it to be one thing, and you another, and then when we have proceeded some little way in our conference, we may perceive how ridiculous we are, I the adviser and you the advised, in having no common ground in our notions.

Demodocus: Why, I think you are right there, Socrates, and we should do as you suggest.

Socrates: Yes, I am right, but yet not entirely, because I have a slight change to make. For it occurs to me that [122d] this youngster may not be desiring the thing that we suppose him to desire, but something else, and there again we may be still more absurdly taking counsel on some other thing. Hence our most

proper course, it seems to me, is to begin with the youth himself, and inquire of him what it actually is that he desires.

Demodocus: It does rather look, in fact, as though our best way would be thus, as you suggest.

Socrates: Then tell me, what is the young person's goodly name: how are we to address him?

Demodocus: Theages is his name, Socrates. [122e]

Socrates: Goodly is the name, Demodocus, and holy-sounding, that you have bestowed on your son. Tell me, then, Theages, do you say you desire to become wise, and do you require your father here to find out a school of some man who is qualified to make you wise?

Theages: Yes.

Socrates: And which sort of man do you call wise, those who have knowledge of such and such a thing, whatever it may be, or those who have not?

Theages: Those who have knowledge, I say.

Socrates: Well now, has not your father taught and educated you in the subjects which form the education of everyone else here — all the sons of noble and honorable fathers — in letters, I mean, and harping and wrestling and the other sorts of contest? [123a]

Theages: Yes, he has.

Socrates: And you think you are still lacking in some knowledge which it behoves your father to provide for you?

Theages: I do

Socrates: What knowledge is it? Tell us on our side, that we may oblige you.

Theages: He knows it, as well as I, Socrates, since I have often told him; only he says this to you of set purpose, making as if he did not know what I desire. For he assails me too with other statements of the same sort, and refuses to place me with any instructor. [123b]

Socrates: Well, what you said to him before was spoken, as it were, without witnesses; but now you shall take me as a witness, and declare before me what is this wisdom that you desire. Come now; suppose you desired the wisdom whereby men steer a ship, and I happened to put this further question to you: Theages, what wisdom is it that you lack, when you blame your father for refusing to place you with people who would enable you to become wise? What answer would you have given me? What wisdom would you name? The steersman's art, would you not?

Theages: Yes. [123c]

Socrates: And if a desire to be wise in the wisdom whereby they steer chariots led you to blame your father, and I asked what wisdom this was, what would you name in reply? The charioteer's art, would you not?

Theages: Yes.

Socrates: And is that which you happen to be desiring now a nameless one, or has it a name?

Theages: I should say it has a name.

Socrates: Now do you know it, though not its name, or do you know its name as well?

Theages: I know its name as well.

Socrates: Then what is it? Tell me. [123d]

Theages: What other name, Socrates, can one give it but wisdom?

Socrates: And the driver's art too is wisdom? Or do you think it is ignorance?

Theages: I do not.

Socrates: You call it wisdom?

Theages: Yes.

Socrates: What use do we make of it? Is it not the art whereby we know how to govern a team of horses?

Theages: Yes.

Socrates: And the steersman's art too is wisdom?

Theages: I think so.

Socrates: Is not this the art whereby we know how to govern ships?

Theages: Yes, it is.

Socrates: And the wisdom that you so desire, what is it? [123e]
That whereby we know how to govern whom?

Theages: To govern men, I imagine.

Socrates: Sick men, do you mean?

Theages: Oh, no.

Socrates: For that is medicine, is it not?

Theages: Yes.

Socrates: Well, that whereby we know how to govern the singers in a chorus?

Theages: No.

Socrates: For that is music?

Theages: To be sure.

Socrates: Well, that whereby we know how to govern men in gymnastic training?

Theages: No.

Socrates: For that is gymnastics?

Theages: Yes.

Socrates: Well, to govern people who do what? Endeavor your best to speak, as I did to you at the beginning. [124a]

Theages: To govern the people in the city, I imagine.

Socrates: And are the sick people also in the city?

Theages: Yes, but I mean not these only, but all the rest who are in the city besides.

Socrates: Do I understand what art it is that you mean? For you strike me as meaning, not that whereby we know how to govern reapers and harvesters and planters and sowers and threshers, for it is the farmer's art whereby we govern these, is it not?

Theages: Yes. [124b]

Socrates: Nor, I suppose, do you mean that whereby we know how to govern sawyers and borers and planers and turners, as a class together; for is not that carpentry?

Theages: Yes.

Socrates: But perhaps it is that whereby we govern, not only all these, but farmers themselves also, and carpenters, and all craftsmen and ordinary people, whether men or women: that, perhaps, is the wisdom you mean.

Theages: That, Socrates, is what I have been intending to mean all the time. [124c]

Socrates: Then can you tell me whether Aegisthus, who slew Agamemnon in Argos, governed all these people that you mean

craftsmen and ordinary people, both men and women, or some other persons?

Theages: No, just those.

Socrates: Well now, did not Peleus, son of Aeacus, govern these same people in Phthia?

Theages: Yes.

Socrates: And have you ever heard of Periander, son of Cypselus, and how he governed at Corinth?

Theages: I have.

Socrates: Did he not govern these same people in his city?
[124d]

Theages: Yes.

Socrates: Or again, do you not consider that Archelaus, son of Perdiccas, who governed recently in Macedonia, governed these same people?

Theages: I do.

Socrates: And who do you think were governed by Hippias, son of Peisistratus, who governed in this city? Were they not these people?

Theages: To be sure they were.

Socrates: Now, can you tell me what appellation is given to Bacis and Sibyl and our native Amphilytus?

Theages: Why, soothsayers, of course, Socrates. [124e]

Socrates: That is correct. But try to answer me in that way regarding those others — Hippias and Periander: what appellation is given them on account of their government?

Theages: Despots, I suppose; it must be that.

Socrates: And when a man desires to govern the whole of the people in his city, he desires the same government as those did — despotism, and to be a despot?

Theages: Apparently.

Socrates: And it is this that you say you desire?

Theages: It seems so, from what I have said. [125a]

Socrates: You scoundrel! So you were desiring to govern us, all the time that you were blaming your father for not sending you to some seminary of despots! And you, Demodocus, are you not ashamed of having known all the time what he is desiring, and though you could have sent him where you would have made him an expert in the wisdom which he desires, actually grudging it to him and refusing to send him? But now, look here, as he has declared against you in my presence, shall you and I consult together on the question of whose school we shall send him to, and whose classes will help him to become a wise despot? [125b]

Demodocus: Yes, in faith, Socrates, let us certainly consult, as I feel this is a matter on which no slight counsel is needed.

Socrates: By and by, my good sir. Let us first cross-examine him thoroughly.

Demodocus: Examine him then.

Socrates: Well now, what if we called in Euripides to our aid, Theages? For you know Euripides says: "Despots are wise by converse with the wise.

"Soph. Fr. 14.15 Now, if someone should ask Euripides: Euripides, in what [125c] are these men wise, by whose converse you say that despots are wise? I mean, suppose he had said: "Farmers are wise by converse with the wise, "and we had asked him, — Wise in what? — what answer would he have given us? Surely none other than, — In

farming.

Theages: That, and none other.

Socrates: Or again, if he had said: "Piemens are wise by converse with the wise,
"and we had asked him, Wise in what? — what answer would he have given us? He would have said, — In the pie-making business, — would he not?

Theages: Yes.

Socrates: Or again, if he had said "Wrestlers are wise by converse with the wise,
"and we had asked him, Wise in what? — would he not reply,
— [125d] In wrestling?

Theages: Yes.

Socrates: But as he said: "Despots are wise by converse with the wise,
"? Soph. Fr. 14.1 and we ask him, — In what do you mean that the latter are wise, Euripides? — what will he reply? What sort of subjects will he mention here?

Theages: Why, upon my word, I for my part do not know.

Socrates: Well, do you mind if I tell you?

Theages: If you do not mind.

Socrates: They are the same subjects that Anacreon said Callicrite understood; or do you not know the ode?

Theages: I do.

Socrates: Well then, do you desire to partake in some instruction of that sort from any man [125e] who is a fellow-craftsman of Callicrite, daughter of Cyane, and knows all about despotism as she did, according to the poet, in order that you may become a despot over us and our city?

Theages: You are joking all this time, Socrates, and making fun of me.

Socrates: Why, do you not say that you desire that wisdom which will enable you to govern all the citizens? And in doing that, will you be anything else but a despot ?

Theages: I should indeed pray, I imagine, that I might become a despot, [126a] if possible, over all men, and failing that, over as many as might be; so would you, I imagine, and everybody else besides: nay, even more, I daresay, that I might become a god; but I did not say I desired that.

Socrates: Well, what on earth then is it that you do desire? Do you not say you desire to govern the citizens?

Theages: Yes, but not by force, or as despots do, but with their consent, as is done by all the other men of importance in the state.

Socrates: Do you mean, as by Themistocles and Pericles and Cimon, and by all those who have shown themselves able statesmen?

Theages: Yes, in good earnest, I mean those people. [126b]

Socrates: Then what if you chanced to desire to become wise in horsemanship? To whom would you have had to resort before expecting to be a clever horseman? To whom else but the horse-masters?

Theages: To none else, I am sure.

Socrates: And moreover, you would go to the actual men who are clever at the business, and who have horses and constantly use them in great numbers, both their own and other people's?

Theages: Obviously I should.

Socrates: And what if you wished to become wise in javelin-throwing? Would you not expect to get this wisdom by having resorted to those javelin-masters who have javelins and who constantly use javelins, [126c] both other people's and their own, in great numbers?

Theages: I think so.

Socrates: Then pray tell me, since it is your wish to become wise in state-matters, do you expect to get your wisdom by resorting to any other persons than those statesmen, who not only have their own ability in state-matters, but have constant dealings with other cities besides their own, by their intercourse alike with Greek cities and with foreign peoples? Or do you think to get wisdom in their business by resorting to any other persons than these particular men? [126d]

Theages: Well, Socrates, I have heard of the argument that you are said to put forward — that the sons of those statesmen are no better men than the sons of shoemakers; and in my opinion your words are very true, from what I am able to gather. Hence I should be an utter fool if I supposed that any of these men would impart his wisdom to me when he never was of any use to his own son, as he would have been, if he were able to be of use in this matter to anyone at all in the world.

Socrates: Then which way, most excellent sir, would you turn if, when you came to have a son, he should trouble you in the same manner, [126e] and tell you he desired to become a good painter, and should blame you, his father, for refusing to spend money on him for that very purpose, but at the same time should disregard the practitioners of that very thing, the painters, and decline to learn from them? Or the flute-players, when he wished to become a flute-player, or the harp-players? Would you know what to do with him, and where else you should send him if he refused to learn from these?

Theages: Upon my word, I should not. [127a]

Socrates: And do you now, when you are behaving in just the same way to your father, feel surprised and blame him for being at a loss what to do with you and where to send you? Why, we are ready to place you with any well-bred Athenian statesman you may choose, who will train you free of charge; and so not only will you be at no expense of money, but will gain far greater commendation amongst the mass of men than if you studied with anyone else.

Theages: But then, Socrates, are not you too one of our well-bred gentlemen? Indeed, if you will agree to instruct me, I am content and seek no other. [127b]

Socrates: What do you mean by that, Theages?

Demodocus: Nay, Socrates, there is nothing amiss in what he says, and you will oblige me at the same time; for I should count it the greatest possible stroke of luck if he should welcome your instruction and you also should consent to instruct him. Nay, indeed, I am quite ashamed to say how keenly I wish it; but I entreat you both — you, to consent to teach Theages, and you, to seek the teaching of no one else than Socrates; you will thus relieve me [127c] of a harassing load of anxiety. For just now I am sorely afraid of his falling in with some other person who is likely to corrupt him.

Theages: Have no more fears for me now, father, so long as you are able to persuade him to receive me as his pupil.

Demodocus: Very rightly spoken. Socrates, from now onward we must address ourselves to you; for I am ready, in short, to place both myself and all that I hold dearest of what is mine in your hands — whatever you may require, [127d] absolutely — if you will open your arms to Theages here, and do him any service that you can.

Socrates: Demodocus, your zeal is no wonder to me, if you suppose that I especially could be of use to him; for I know of nothing for which a sensible man could be more zealous than for his own son's utmost improvement. But how you came to form this opinion, that I would be better able to be of use to your son in his aim of becoming a good citizen than you would yourself, and how he came to suppose that I rather than yourself would be of use to him — this does fill me with wonder. For you, [127e] in the first place, are my elder, and further, you have held in your time many of the highest offices in Athens, and are respected by the people of Anagyrus above all your fellow-townsmen, and by the whole state as much as any man, whereas neither of you can notice anything like this about me. And moreover, if Theages here does despise the instruction of our statesmen, and is looking for some other persons who profess to be able to educate young people, we have here Prodicus of Ceos, Gorgias of Leontini, Polus of Acragas, [128a] and many more, who are so wise that they go to our cities and persuade the noblest and wealthiest of our young men — who have the choice of learning from any citizen they choose, free of charge — they persuade them to abandon that instruction and learn from them, with a deposit, besides, of a large sum of money as their fee, and to feel thankful in addition. Some of these persons might naturally have been chosen both by your son and by yourself, in preference to me; [128b] for I have no knowledge of those fair and beatific subjects of study: I only wish that I had. But what I always say, you know, is that I am in the position of knowing practically nothing except one little subject, that of love-matters. In this subject, however, I claim to be skilled above anybody who has ever lived or is now living in the world.

Theages: Do you see, father? Socrates does not seem to me to be at all willing now to spend his time on me; for there is readiness enough on my part, [128c] if he is willing. But he is only jesting

in what he has just told us. For I know of some of my equals in age, and some a little older, who were of no account before they learnt from him, but after beginning to learn from him have in a very short time proved themselves superior to all whose inferiors they were before.

Socrates: And do you know what the meaning of it is, son of Demodocus?

Theages: Yes, on my soul, I do — that, if it be your pleasure, I too shall be able to become such as those others are. [128d]

Socrates: No, good sir, the meaning of it escapes you; but I will tell it you. There is something spiritual which, by a divine dispensation, has accompanied me from my childhood up. It is a voice that, when it occurs, always indicates to me a prohibition of something I may be about to do, but never urges me on to anything; and if one of my friends consults me and the voice occurs, the same thing happens: it prohibits, and does not allow him to act. And I will produce witnesses to convince you of these facts. You know our Charmides here, who has grown so handsome, the son of Glaucon: [128e] he once happened to be consulting me on his intention of training for the Nemean races, and he had no sooner begun to say that he intended to train than the voice occurred, and I tried to prevent him, saying—“Just as you were speaking my spirit-voice has occurred: no, you must not train.” “Perhaps,” said he, “it indicates to you that I shall not win; but even if I am not to win, at any rate the exercise I shall get in the meantime will do me good.” So saying, he went and trained; and so you may as well inquire of him [129a] as to the results he got from his training. Or if you like, ask Cleitomachus, brother of Timarchus, what Timarchus said to him when he was going straight to the prison to meet his death, he and Euathlus the racing runner, who had harbored Timarchus as a fugitive; for he will tell you that the words he spoke to him were these:

Theages: What?

Socrates: “Cleitomachus,” he said, “I tell you I am going to my death now, because I would not take Socrates’ advice.” Now, why on earth did Timarchus say that? I will tell you. When Timarchus and Philemon, [129b] son of Philemonides, got up from the wine-party to kill Nicias, son of Heroscamandrus, those two alone had knowledge of the plot; and Timarchus, as he got up, said to me: “What say you, Socrates? Go on drinking, all of you; I have to get up and go somewhere, but I will join you a little later, if I get the chance.” Then occurred that voice of mine, and I said to him: “No, no, do not get up; for my accustomed spiritual sign has occurred to me.” [129c] So he stopped. Then after an interval of time he again started to go, and said: “Well, I am going, Socrates.” Again the voice occurred, and so again I constrained him to stop. The third time, wishing to give me the slip, he got up without saying another word to me; he gave me the slip by watching until my attention was turned elsewhere. Thus it was that he went right off and committed the deed which was the cause of his going then to his death. And hence it was that he spoke those words to his brother which I quoted to you just now, that he was going to his death because he had not taken my advice. [129d] And moreover, in regard to the Sicilian business, many will tell you what I said about the destruction of the army. As to bygones, you may hear from those who know: but there is an opportunity now of testing the worth of what the sign says. For as the handsome Sannio was setting out on campaign, the sign occurred to me, and he has gone now with Thrasyllus on an expedition bound for Ephesus and Ionia. I accordingly expect him to be either killed or brought very near it, and I have great fears for our force as a whole. [129e]

Now I have told you all this, because this spiritual power that attends me also exerts itself to the full in my intercourse with

those who spend their time with me. To many, indeed, it is adverse, and it is not possible for these to get any good by conversing with me, and I am therefore unable to spend my time in conversing with them. And there are many with whom it does not prohibit my intercourse, yet the intercourse does them no good. But those who are assisted in their intercourse by that spiritual power are the persons whom you have noticed; for they make rapid progress there and then. And of these, again, who make progress some find the benefit [130a] both solid and enduring; while there are many who, for as long a time as they are with me, make wonderful progress, but when they are parted from me relapse, and are no different from anybody else. This once befell Aristides, son of Lysimachus, son of Aristides. For by conversing with me he had made immense progress in a little time; and then he had to go on an expedition, and he went and sailed away. On his return he found that Thucydides, son of Melesias, son of Thucydides, had been conversing with me. Now Thucydides, the day before, had quarrelled with me [130b] over some arguments we had had. So when Aristides saw me, after greeting me and talking of other affairs, he said: "But Thucydides, I hear, Socrates, is somewhat on his dignity with you, and is annoyed as though he were somebody. "Yes, that is so," I replied. "Well, but does he not know," he said, "what a sad slave he was, before he associated with you?" "It seems not," I replied, "upon my soul." "But indeed I myself also," he said, "am in a ridiculous position, [130c] Socrates." "How exactly?" I asked. "Because," he replied, "before I sailed away, I was able to discuss things with anybody, and show myself inferior to none in argument, so that I even sought out the debates of the most accomplished people: but now, on the contrary, I shun them, wherever I notice there is anyone of education, so ashamed I am of my own ineptitude." "Tell me," I said, "did this power forsake you of a sudden, or little by little?" "Little by little," he replied. "And when it was

present with you,” I asked, [130d] “was it present through your having learnt something from me, or in some other way?” “I will tell you, Socrates,” he said, “what is incredible, upon my soul, yet true. For I never yet learnt anything from you, as you know yourself: but I made progress, whenever I was with you, if I was merely in the same house, without being in the same room, but more progress, when I was in the same room. And it seemed to me to be much more when I was in the same room and looked at you as you were speaking, than when [130e] I turned my eyes elsewhere: but my progress was far the greatest and most marked whenever I sat beside you and held and touched you. Now, however,” he said, “that condition has all oozed away.”

Such then, Theages, is the intercourse you would have with me: if God so wills, you will make very great and rapid progress, but otherwise, you will not. Consider, therefore, if it is not safer for you to be educated by one of those persons who have command themselves of the benefit which they bestow on mankind, rather than follow the course on which you may chance with me. [131a]

Theages: Well then, I decide, Socrates, that our plan shall be to make trial of that spiritual sign by associating with each other. Thus, if it leaves us free, that will be best of all; if it does not, it will be time then for us to consider, at the moment, what we shall do — whether we shall associate with someone else, or try to conciliate the divine sign itself that occurs to you with prayers and sacrifices and anything else that the seers may indicate.

Demodocus: In view of this, Socrates, say no more in opposition to the lad; for Theages is right in what he says.

Socrates: Well, if you consider that this is what we ought to do, let us do it.

Sisyphus

ΣΙΣΥΦΟΣ

Plato

translated by George Burges

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Socrates: And we too waited a long time for you yesterday, Sisyphus, at the display made by Stratonicus, in order that you might, together with us, hear a clever man, who both by word and deed exhibited many and beautiful things; and when we thought you would no longer be present, we were by ourselves the hearers of the man.

Sis.: Truly by Zeus. For a want of leisure of rather a compulsory kind occurred to me, so that I neglected the display. For our rulers had a consultation yesterday, and they compelled me to consult with them. Now with us Pharsalians it is a law to obey the rulers, should they order any of us to consult with them.

Socrates: And honourable it is to obey the law and to be reputed by fellow-citizens to be a good counsellor, as you are [reputed to be a good counsellor as one of the Pharsalians]. But, Sisyphus, although I should not be able to enter upon a discussion against you on the subject of consulting correctly, conceiving it to be a work requiring much leisure, and a lengthy argument, still I would endeavour to converse with you first about consulting in the abstract, what it is. Can you then tell me what it is to consult in the abstract? Do not (tell) me what it is to do so well or ill or in any manner, but what kind of thing it is alone by itself. For you could well and easily tell, being so good a counsellor. But (I fear) lest it is a superfluous work for me to make of you the inquiry.

Sis.: Is it then unknown to you what it is to consult?

Socrates: It is, Sisyphus, to myself at least, if it be any thing else than for a person, who does not know any thing of those matters respecting which it is requisite to do some act, to speak like a diviner and off-handed, whatever may present itself, and to make a guess according to the same things for himself; like persons playing at odd and even, who, knowing nothing about the even and odd, which they hold in their own hands,

nevertheless happen by accident to say what is true about the same things. To consult then is oftentimes a thing of this kind, that a person, although knowing nothing of the matters, about which he is consulting, yet happens by accident to say what is the truth. If then it is a thing of this kind, I know what to consult is; if however it is not a thing of this kind, I should not know it at all.

Sis.: It is not of such a kind as not to know in reality any thing at all, but to know partly something of the matter in hand, and partly not to know at all.

Socrates: Do you mean that to consult is, by Zeus, a thing of this kind; that, as I seem to myself to divine somewhat your notions relating to the act of consulting well, it is the seeking to discover the best things for a person to employ himself in for his own benefit, but not to know them clearly, but for this to be, as it were, in some form of a thought? Do you not mean somehow in this way.

Sis.: I do.

Socrates: Whether do men seek such things as they know, or such as they do not know?

Sis.: Both.

Socrates: Do you mean by this something of this kind, that men seek both what they know and what they do not know? just as if a person should know Callistratus, who he is; but not know to find where he is, not who is Callistratus. Do you mean that to seek both is after this manner.

Sis.: I do.

Socrates: He then, who knows Callistratus, would not seek that matter, namely, to know him.

Sis.: He would not.

Socrates: But he would, where he might be.

Sis.: It seems so to myself at least.

Socrates: Nor would he seek even this, namely, where it was possible to find him, if he knew already; but he would find him forthwith.

Sis.: Yes.

Socrates: Men then do not seek the things, which they know, but, as it seems, what they do not know. But if this reasoning appears to you to be of a captious kind, and to have been spoken, not for the sake of a practical purpose, but for conversation merely, consider the matter in this way, if the case seems to be such as has been just now stated. Do you not know that this takes place in geometry? that by geometricians the diameter is not unknown, whether it be a diameter or not, — for this I well know is not sought to be discovered by them, — but how great it is in measurement in proportion to the sides of the space which it intersects? Is not this the very thing which is sought respecting it?

Sis.: So it seems at least to me.

Socrates: For it is that, which is unknown. Is it not so?

Sis.: Certainly.

Socrates: Know you not that the doubling of the cube is sought to be discovered by geometricians, how great it is by calculation? But the cube itself is not sought for by them, whether it is a cube, or not; for that at least they know well. Is it not so?

Sis.: Yes.

Socrates: Respecting the air likewise, do you not know that Anaxagoras and Empedocles, and the rest of those, who talk about meteorology, are all seeking whether it is boundless or

has a limit?

Sis.: Yes I do.

Socrates: But not the question, whether it is air. Is it not so?

Sis.: It is.

Socrates: Will you then agree with me that such is the case with all other things now that to no person is there any seeking after the things he knows, but rather after those which he does not know?

Sis.: I will.

Socrates: Did not the consulting appear to us to be this very thing, namely, that a person is seeking after the best things relating to what he would require to employ himself in for his own benefit.

Sis.: Yes.

Socrates: And the seeking was, like the consulting, about things to be done. Is it not so?

Sis.: Entirely.

Socrates: Must we not consider then at present, what impediment is in the way of those, who are seeking, to the discovery of the things, about which they are making the search?

Sis.: So it seems at least to me.

Socrates: Could we say that any thing else was an impediment to them except a want of knowledge?

(Sis. Nothing else).

Socrates: Let us, by Zeus, consider the matter very much, letting out, as the saying is, every rope, and sending out every voice. And view thou this point with me. Think you that a man

could consult about music, who knows nothing of music; or how he ought to play on the guitar, or to perform any thing according to the musician's art?

Sis.: Not I indeed.

Socrates: What then, as regards generalship, or piloting? Do you think that the person, who knows neither of those arts, would have it in his power to consult about either of those matters, as to what is to be done by him, and how, who knows not to act the general or pilot?

Sis.: I do not.

Socrates: Do you think then that the case is so respecting all other matters, of which a person knows nothing; that it is not possible for him even to consult, who knows nothing about them?

Sis.: I do.

Socrates: But it is (possible) for him to seek (to know). Is it not?

Sis.: Certainly.

Socrates: To seek then would not be the same as to consult.

Sis.: How could it?

Socrates: Because to seek is surely applied to the matters, which a person does not know; but it seems to be not possible for a person to consult about those matters, of which he is ignorant. Or has not this been said correctly?

Sis.: Very much so.

Socrates: Ye were then yesterday seeking to discover what was best for the state; but ye did not know it. For if ye had known, ye would not surely have been seeking it, just as we do not seek any thing amongst those which we know. Is it not so?

Sis.: It is.

Socrates: Whether does it seem to you, Sisyphus, if a person does not know, that he ought to seek or to learn?

Sis.: To myself at least it seems, by Zeus, to learn.

Socrates: And correctly does it seem so. But does it seem to you that he ought to learn rather than seek on this account, because a person would discover more quickly and easily, if he learnt from those, who know, than if he were to seek himself what he did not know? Or is it on some other account?

Sis.: On no other than this.

Why did ye not then yesterday, disregarding the act of consulting about matters, of which ye knew nothing, and of seeking to do the best for the state, learn from some one of those, who did know, how ye might do the best for the state? But ye seem to me to have been sitting the whole of yesterday and speaking off-hand, and prophesying about matters, of which ye were ignorant, and neglecting to learn, both the rulers of the state and you together with them. But perhaps you will say that this has been played off by myself against you for the sake of a conversation merely, and it has not been proved to you seriously. Consider then, by Zeus, this question at least for the present with seriousness. If it were conceded that to consult is something, and not, as now discovered, to be nothing else than a knowledge according to conjecture, and a speaking off-hand, making use of merely a more solemn name, but nothing else, do you think, that as regards the act of consulting well and being good counsellors, persons differ one from another on that point, as persons [differ one from another] on all the other kinds of knowledge, (such as) carpenters from carpenters, physicians from physicians, and hautboy-players from hautboy-players, and all the rest of handicraftsmen differ from each other? As then those engaged in these arts (differ), think you that in the act of consulting persons would differ at all in

this manner, one from another?

Sis.: Yes I do.

Socrates: Now tell me, do not all, both those who consult well, and those who do so ill, consult about matters that are about to be?

Sis.: Certainly.

Socrates: Is the future any thing else than what is not as yet?

Sis.: It is not.

Socrates: For if it were, it would not surely be still about", to be, but it would be already. Is it not so?

Sis.: Yes.

Socrates: Therefore that, which is not yet, in reality has not been produced.

Sis.: It has not.

Socrates: Therefore that, which is not and has not been produced, has no existence in reality.

Sis.: It has not.

Socrates: Do not all, then, who consult well or ill, consult about things which neither are, nor have been, and which have no existence, when they consult respecting things about to be?

Sis.: At least they seem so.

Socrates: Does it seem to you possible for a person to hit well or ill a thing, that does not exist?

Sis.: How say you this?

Socrates: I will explain, what I mean to say. Consider then. How would you distinguish out of many archers, which of them was the good and (which) the bad?

Sis.: Surely this is not difficult to know.

Socrates: 'For perhaps you would bid them shoot at some mark. Is it not so?

Sis.: Certainly.

Socrates: Would you not decide that he is the conqueror, who hits most often the mark in a direct way.

Sis.: Yes, I would.

Socrates: But if there were no mark laid down for them to shoot at, but each shot where he liked, how could you distinguish between the good and bad archer?

Sis.: Not at all.

Socrates: Would you then not be at a loss to distinguish between those consulting well or ill, if they did not know what they were consulting about?

Sis.: Yes, I should.

Socrates: Do not those then, who consult respecting things about to be, consult respecting things not in existence?

Sis.: Certainly.

Socrates: It is not therefore possible for any person to hit the thing not in existence. For how does any one seem to you to be able to hit, what is not in existence?

Sis.: Not at all.

Socrates: Since then it is not possible to hit, what is not in existence, no one would be able to hit any thing of those not in existence by consulting. For things that are about to be belong to those not in existence. Is it not so?

Sis.: So it seems at least to me.

Socrates: He then, who does not hit things about to be, would be amongst men neither a good counsellor, nor a bad counsellor.

Sis.: It seems he would not.

Socrates: Nor is a person (said) to be either a better counsellor, or a worse counsellor, not even if he should be more successful or less successful in hitting, what is not in existence.

Sis.: He is not.

Socrates: Looking then to what circumstance men call certain persons by the name of good counsellors, or bad counsellors, is it not worthy, Sisyphus, to think again upon this matter?

Sis.: (I say so).

Axiochus

ΑΞΙΟΧΟΣ

Plato

translated by George Burges

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Soc.: When I had gone out on the road to Cynosarges,- and had arrived at the Ilissus, the voice of some one reached me, calling out, “ Socrates, Socrates.” And when on turning towards (the sound) I looked round to see from whence it might be, I beheld Clinias, the son of Axiochus, running towards the fountain Callirrhoe, together with Damon the musician, and Charmides, the son of Glaucon. Of these, one was the other’s music-master, and the other was, from a feeling of friendship, at once the loving and beloved. I determined therefore to give up the direct road, and to meet them, that we might come together in the easiest manner. And Clinias, with tears in his eyes, said — Now, Socrates, is the time for you to exhibit the wisdom ever bruited by you. For my father has at some sudden season become powerless, and is at the end of life, and with pain supports the idea of dissolution; although at a former period he used to ridicule those, who were afraid of the bugbear of death, and to rebuke them mildly. Come then, and console him as you are wont, in order that he may without a groan proceed on the road of fate, and that, together with the remaining acts of piety, this too may be done by me. In no moderate matter, Clinias, (said I,) shall you be disappointed in me; especially as you are inviting me to do a holy act. Let us then make haste; for if such is the state of affairs, there is a need of haste.

Clin.: On merely seeing you, Socrates, he will rally; for often has he been on his legs again after a (serious) symptom. Soc. When we had traversed rather quickly the road along the wall, at the Itonian gates — for he dwells near there, close to the pillar of the Amazon — we came upon him, when he had already recovered his senses, and his body some strength, although his mind was weak, and he stood greatly in need of consolation; and frequently did he raise himself up, and give vent to moans, together with the shedding of tears, and the noisy beating of his hands. On beholding him, Why is this, Axiochus? said I. Where are your former boastings and frequent praises of virtue, and

your boldness not to be broken down? since, like a cowardly combatant, you have exhibited yourself of noble bearing in the place of exercise, but have failed in the fight. Will not you, a man of so long a life, and the hearer of (the finest) reasonings, and, if nothing else, at least an Athenian, after surveying nature consider that this is surely a common (saying), and bruited amongst all, that life is a kind of sojourn (upon earth); and that we must pass through it in a reasonable and good-tempered manner, and take our departure, only not singing paeans on the road to fate; while to conduct yourself in so cowardly a manner, and to be torn with difficulty from existence, is to exhibit, like a child, a period of life not otherwise.

Axio.: This, Socrates, is true; and you appear to me to speak correctly. And yet I know not how, when I am at the very point of what is dreadful, those powerful and very clever reasonings unconsciously fall away, and are held in no honour; while in their stead a fear lays hold of me, tearing my mind in various ways, if I am to be deprived of this light here, and of the good things (of life), and to lie rotting, wherever it may be, unseen and unheard of, after passing into worms and nondescript creatures.

Soc.: Through your own ignorance, Axiochus, you are combining sensation with the want of sensation; and you are acting and speaking in a manner at variance with yourself; and you do not consider that you are at one and the same time lamenting your want of sensation, and pained at the idea of your rotting away, and of being deprived of what is pleasant, as if you are to die and live in another state, and not to pass into insensibility complete, and the same as that before you were born. As then none of the mischief during the political period of Draco and Clisthenes pertained to yourself — for you, to whom it might have pertained, did not exist at all — so it will not after death occur to you; for you, to whom it might occur, will not be

in existence. Throw aside then all silliness of this kind, and think upon this, that, after the union of soul with body has been once dissolved by the former being settled in its own home-place, what is left of the latter is of the earth and devoid of reason, nor is it a man. For we are soul, a thing of life and immortal, pent up in a mortal prison. And nature has for some mischief fitted round this tabernacle, to which pleasant things are in a recess, and on the wing, and mixed up with the majority of pains; but the things of sorrow are unmixed, and last a long time, and have no share in what is pleasant: (I say nothing) of diseases and inflammations in the sensoria and of internal ills, with which the soul, as if sown with pores, does, when it sympathizes, of necessity desire its congenial atmosphere of heaven, and feels a thirst for the life that is there, and a hankering after its dancing; so that a removal from this life is but a change from an evil to a good.

Axio.: Since then, Socrates, you consider life to be an ill, why do you remain in it? and this too, when you are a person of reflection, and excel us, the mass, in mind.

Soc.: You do not, Axiochus, testify truly in my case; but you conceive, as the mass of Athenians do, that, since I am searcher after facts, I am acquainted with something. And indeed I would pray to know all things of even a common kind, so much am I deficient in what are superior. But what I am now saying are the proclaimed doctrines of Prodicus the wise, that have been bought, some for half a drachm, others for two drachms, and others for four; for that person never teaches any thing for nothing, but his custom is perpetually to proclaim the sentiment of Epicharmus — Hand handwashes; give then something, 'and get something in return. And lately, when he was making a display at the house of Callias, the son of Hipponicus, he spoke so much against living, that I drew a line through (the word) life as a thing of the least value; and from

that time, Axiochus, my soul yearned for death.

Axio.: And what was said then?

Soc.: I will tell you all can remember. For what part of life, said he, is free from pain? Does not the infant cry at its first birth, beginning to live from pain? Nor is it deficient in any suffering, but is affected painfully either by the want of something, or excessive cold or heat, or a blow; and being unable to tell what it is suffering, it cries continually, possessing this voice alone of its discontentment. And when it reaches its seventh year, after having gone through many troubles, there are boy-leaders, and teachers of grammar, and drilling-masters tyrannizing over him. And as he grows bigger, there is a still larger- number of despots, who teach him correctness in composition, and geometry, and military tactics.

And when he is registered amongst the young men, there are, what is a worse fear, the Lyceum and Academy, and the Gymnasiarchs and their staves, and a measureless amount of ills. And the whole period of youth is under Moderators and the selection of those placed over young persons by the Council of the Areopagus. And when he is forced from them, cares straightway come upon him in secret, and considerations as to what road of life he is to tread; and (compared with) the after difficulties the first appear to be childish, and the terrors in truth of infants; for there are campaigns, and wounds, and continuous contests. And then old age stealthily and unconsciously comes on, to which flow together all that is on the verge of death and hard to be remedied. And should a person not pay, as a debt, his life rather quickly, Nature, like an usurer, stands near and takes as a pledge from one his eye-sight, and from another his hearing, and frequently both; and should he still delay, she brings on a paralysis, (or) a mutilation (or) a distortion of limbs; while they, who on the threshold of old age are still vigorous, in mind, become twice children, though

grown old. And hence even the gods, who take cognizance of human affairs, release more quickly from life those, on whom they set the greatest value. For example, Agamedes and Trophonius, who built up the close, sacred to the god at Pytlio, did, after praying that the best thing might befall them, lay themselves on their bed and never rise from it again. So too the sons of the priestess at Argos, after their mother had in like manner prayed for some honour to be paid them by Juno in return for their piety, when, through the pair (of mules) being too late, they undressed themselves, and drew her (in the car) to the temple, they did, after the prayer, change, during the night, their existence. And long would be the story to go through of the poets, who, with their more divine mouths, have told in holy hymns the tales relating to life, how they utter lamentations against living. Of one alone I will however remember me, the most worthy to be spoken of, who says, The gods for mortals, in a hapless state To live, in sorrow wove the web of fate — and, (II. xvii.,)

Of all that breathe and creep upon the earth, There's nought than man more wretched (from his birth).

And what does he say of Amphiraus? (Od. xv. .) Him heartily the Egis-bearing Zeus Loved, and Apollo with the feelings all Of friendship; yet he did not of old age The threshold reach.

And what does he appear to you, who bids us Weep for the ills, to which the new-born comes.

But I will stop here, lest, contrary to my engagement, I become prolix by making mention of others likewise. With what pursuit or art does not he, who has chosen it, find fault, and is discontented with his present state? Let us go to handicraftsmen and workers at a furnace, who labour from night to night, and with difficulty procure the necessities of life, and let (us hear) them bewailing their fate and filling up

their sleepless hours with lamentations and tears. Or let us reckon up the sailor's (life), passed in the midst of so many dangers', and which, as Bias has shown, is neither amongst the living nor the dead; for the man who belongs to earth, has, as if he were amphibious, thrown himself upon the sea, and become wholly in the power of fortune. But farming is at least a pleasant thing. Clearly so. But is it not wholly a sore, for ever finding for itself a pretext for sorrow? crying now at a drought; now at a continued rain; now at a burning up; now at a mildew; now at unseasonable heat or cold. And the much-honoured statesmanship — for many things I pass over — through revolutions how great is it driven, while it possesses a pleasure, like that of a state of fever, in its quiverings and palpitations, but a failure, full of pain, and worse than a thousand deaths. Who then living for the mob can be happy? even if he has been favourably received with a gentle buzz, or noisy hubbub, as the plaything of the people, (but afterwards) rejected, hissed, fined, put to death, and pitied. Tell me this, thou statesman, Axiochus, where died Miltiades? where Themistocles? where Ephialtes? and where recently the ten army-leaders? when I did not put (the question) to the vote; for it did not seem to me a solemn act to hold office in union with a maddened mob; whereas Theramenes and Callixenus did on the day after introduce secretly fictitious chairmen (of the meeting), and got against the men a vote of death without a trial; and yet did you (Axiochus) lawfully defend them and Euryptolemus likewise, while thirty thousand were at the general meeting.

Axio.: It is so, Socrates. And from that time I have had enough of the platform, and nothing has seemed to me more disagreeable than statesmanship. And this is plain to those who have been engaged in the business. And you indeed speak thus, as taking a view from a look-out; but we, who have made the experiment, know it more accurately. For the mob, my dear Socrates, is a thing ungrateful, satiated with the mere touch,

cruel, envious, uneducated, as being made up of a mass of persons brought together, violent (and) triflers; while he, who acts the courtesan to it, is more miserable by far.

Soc.: Since then, Axiochus, you lay down the science, which is the most free, as the least to be prayed for amongst the rest, what shall we think of the remaining pursuits? Are they not to be avoided? I once indeed heard Prodicus saying that death does not exist as regards either the living or those, who have changed their existence.

Axio.: How say you, Socrates?

Soc.: That as regards the living, it does not exist; while they, who are dead, do not exist; so that neither, as regards you, does it exist; for you are not dead; nor, should you suffer aught, will it exist, as regards you; for you will then not exist. Vain then is the sorrow in Axiochus grieving for Axiochus, touching a thing that neither is nor will be; and it is just the same, as if a person were to grieve for Scylla or the Centaur, which, as regards you, do not exist now, nor will they, after your close of life, exist. For what is fearful is so to those, who exist; but to those, who do not exist, how can it be so?

Axio.: These clever things you have said from the talkativeness, which is floating on the surface (of society) just now. For from thence is this idle speaking, which has been cleverly got up for the young men. But the deprivation of the good things of life is what gives me pain, even should you rattle out reasons, Socrates, still more plausible than those just now. For the mind, when it is wandering, thinks nothing of fine-spoken words; nor do these touch even its surface, which affect indeed a mere pomp and splendour of diction, but are wanting in truth. Now sufferings do not endure sophisms; and upon those things alone, that can reach the soul, rests there any aid.

Soc.: You are putting together, Axiochus, (words) without reason, in bringing the perception of things that are bad as opposed to the deprivation of things that are good, through your forgetting that you are dead. For the counter- suffering of ill pains him who is deprived of good; but he, who does not exist, does not lay hold even of deprivation. How then should there be a grief for that, which is about to furnish no knowledge of the things that will cause pain? For had you, Axiochus, at the beginning laid down (with me), in some way that there is no perception (to the dead), you would not, through your ignorance, have shuddered at death. But now you are turning yourself round, while fearing that you shall be deprived of soul, and place a soul round deprivation; and you fear that you shall not have a perception; and yet you imagine that you shall by perception comprehend a perception, that will not exist. In addition to their being many and beautiful reasons for the immortality of the soul. For a mortal nature would surely not have proceeded and been lifted up to such a greatness in action, as to despise the violence of superior wild animals, and to pass over seas, and to build cities, and to lay down forms of polity, and to look up to heaven and behold the revolutions of the stars, and the courses of the sun and moon, and their eclipses, and rapid return to their former state, and the equality of days, and the two tropical movements, during winter and summer, and the rising and setting of the Pleiades, and the winds, and the fall of rain, and the ill-fated trailing along of fiery meteors, and to lay down on a tablet what the universe is to undergo for ages, unless there had been in the soul some breath of divinity, through which he possessed the power of thinking upon and knowing subjects of so vast a kind; so that you are not, Axiochus, changing your existence for death, but for immortality; nor will you have a deprivation of good things, but a still purer enjoyment of them; nor pleasures mixed up with a mortal body, but unmixed with every pain. For you will,

when released from this prison, depart thither, where all is without trouble, and moanings, and old age, and life is a calm, and with no taste of ill, and where in a mild atmosphere of unruffled tranquillity you (will dwell), looking round upon Nature, and acting the philosopher not before a mob and a theatre, but in the presence of Truth, blooming around.

Axio.: You have by your discourse brought me round to a contrary point. For I have no longer a fear of death, but already a desire to say myself, in imitation of the orators, something still more; and for a long time I have been thinking upon things on high, and I will go through the eternal and divine course, since after my weakness I have collected my strength and am become a new man.

Soc.: (Hear too), if you are willing, another account which Gobryas related to me — a man of the Magi, (who) said that during the expedition of Xerxes, his grandfather, we thus recover a noun, required to govern Πλειάδων, but perceive likewise why the Pleiades are introduced here; since, as we learn from Hesiod Epy. and, both farmers and sailors were wont to pay attention to the rising and setting of the Pleiades, who was his namesake, was sent to Delos to watch over the island, where the two deities presided, according to some brazen tablets, that Opis and Hecaergus had brought from the Hyperboreans; and that he learnt that after the soul was released from the body, it departed to the uncertain spot, and some dwelling under ground, where is the royal palace of Pluto, not less than the hall of Zeus, inasmuch as the earth possesses the middle portion of the world, and the pole (of heaven) is spherical; of which the gods of heaven have obtained by lot one portion of the hemisphere, and the gods below the other, being some of them brothers, and others the children of brothers; and that the gates before the road to Pluto's domain are fast bound by iron locks and keys; and that the river Acheron receives him,

who has opened them, and, after it, Cocytus, both of which it is necessary for him to pass over, and to be led to Minos and Rhadamanthus, (where is) what is called the plain of Truth. There are they seated as judges to sift each of the comers as to what life he had led, and in what pursuits he had dwelt in the body; and that to tell a falsehood is out of his power. On such then as a kind daemon has breathed during life, these are located in the region of the pious. There without stint the seasons bloom with every kind of produce, and fountains of pure water flow; and every where are meadows made beautiful by flowers of varied hues, and places of discussions for philosophers, and theatres of poets, and cyclic choirs, and the hearing of music, and elegant banquets, and feasts self-furnished, and an unmixed freedom from pain, and a delightful mode of living. Nor is produced there violent cold or heat, but a well-tempered air is diffused around, mixed with the sun's mild beams. There is the seat of honour to those, who have shared in the Mysteries; for they perform together their holy rites even thither. How then is there not to you first a share in the honour, as being of the family of the goddesses? And there is a report that Heracles and Dionysus descended to Hades after having previously shared in the Mysteries here; and that they put on a boldness for the journey thither from the Eleusinian (rites). But they, whose life has been passed in a course of evil doings, are driven by the Furies to Erebus and Chaos through Tartarus, where is the region of the impious, and the unfilled urns of the daughters of Danaus, and the thirst of Tantalus, and the entrails of Tityus, and the uncompleted stone of Sisyphus, To whom begins again his labour's end. There too are persons licked round by wild beasts, and terrified by the torches of the Furies glaring around them; and enduring every kind of ignominious treatment, they are by eternal punishments worn down. This account did I hear from Gobryas; and you, Axiochus, can decide upon it. For carried along myself

by reason I know firmly this alone, that the soul is wholly immortal, and that, when it is removed from this spot, it is there without pain; so that it must needs be, Axiochus, that, if you have lived piously, you will be happy either below or above.

Axio.: I am ashamed, Socrates, to say a word. For so far am I from fearing death, that already I feel a desire for it; so greatly has this beautiful discourse of yours persuaded me, as if it were a heavenly one. And even now I have a contempt for life, as being about to remove to a better home. For the present then I will cast up quietly with myself what has been said; and at mid-day you will be with me, Socrates.

Soc.: I will do as you say. And for a while I will go back for a walk to Cynosarges, from whence I was sent for hither.

Demodocus

ΔΗΜΟΔΟΚΟΣ

Plato

translated by George Burges

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You are, Demodocus, requesting me to advise you on the matters, about which you are come together to deliberate. But it has come into my mind to consider, what avails this meeting of yours, and the eagerness of those, who think to advise with you, and the vote, which each of you thinks of giving. For, in the first place, unless it be possible to advise correctly and skilfully on the points, respecting which ye are come to deliberate, how is it not ridiculous for you to come together to deliberate on points, respecting which it is not possible to advise correctly? And in the second place, if it be possible to advise correctly and skilfully upon matters of this kind, still the knowledge, by which it is possible to advise correctly on them, is none. How then is it not out of place? But if there be any knowledge, by which it is possible to advise correctly on such matters, is it not necessary that there should be certain persons skilled to advise correctly on matters of this kind? And if there are certain persons, skilled to advise on those points, about which you are come together to deliberate, is it not necessary for you likewise to know how to advise on these matters, or not to know? Or that some persons should know, and some not? If then all of you know, what need is there for you to come together to deliberate? for each of you is competent to advise. But if, on the other hand, all of you do not know, how will you be able to deliberate? Or what advantage would there be to you in this meeting together, if you are not able to deliberate? But if some of you know, and others do not know, but these are in want of counsel, whether it is possible for an intellectual person to advise the unskilled, even a single person is sufficient to advise with those of you, who do know. Or do not all, who know, advise the same thing? so that it is fitting, after you have heard that person, to separate. But now you do not this; but you wish to hear many giving their advice; for you do not take upon yourselves to know those, who are attempting to advise with you on points, on which they are advising. For if you had taken upon yourselves to know those,

who were advising with you, it would have been sufficient for you to have heard one person alone. To come together then with the view of hearing those, who do not know, as if you were doing something of importance, how is it not a thing out of place? Respecting then this meeting of yours, I am in this way at” a loss.

And that too is a thing of difficulty relating to the eagerness of those, who think they can advise with you. For if, while advising, they do not give the same advice upon the same points, how can they all advise correctly, when they do not advise what he, who advises correctly, would advise? Or how can the eagerness of those, who are eager to advise on points, in which they are unskilled, not be out of place? for being skilled, they would not choose to advise incorrectly. But if, on the other hand, they advise the same, what need is there for them all to advise? for a single one of them would, if advising the same, be sufficient. To be eager then on such matters, as would be of no importance, how is it not ridiculous? Neither then would the eagerness of the unskilled be not out of place, when it is of such a kind; nor would men of sense feel an eagerness on such matters, knowing that even one of them would do the same thing by advising what was fitting; so that I am unable to discover how the eagerness of those, who fancy they are advising, is not ridiculous.

But as regards the vote which you are thinking to give, I am the most at a loss, what it can avail. For whether are you giving a judgment upon those, who know how to advise? But more persons will not advise at all any better than one, nor some one way and others another correctly upon the same matter; so that respecting them there will be no need for you to give a vote. But are you giving a judgment upon some, who are unskilled and who ought not to advise any persons? Surely it is not fitting to intrust to such persons, as if they were madmen, to advise. But

if you are to give a judgment upon neither the skilled nor the unskilled, upon whom are you to give it? But what need is there for other persons to advise with you at all, if you are competent to give a judgment upon such matters? But if on the other hand you are not competent, of what avail are your votes? Or how is it not ridiculous for you to come together, as if about to consult, when you yourselves are in want of advice, and are incompetent, and yet fancy that you ought to come together and give a vote, as if competent to form a judgment? For neither by being taken singly are you ignorant, and become sensible by being taken together; nor, on the other hand, are you at a loss individually, but by coming together are no longer at a loss. But do you become competent to see together what things are to be done by you? and this too, when you have neither learnt them from any one, nor discovered them yourselves; which is the most shocking thing of all. For being unable to see together, what is to be done, you will not be competent to give a judgment upon the party, who is advising you correctly upon these matters; nor, if a person, standing alone, as an adviser, should say this, that he himself will teach you what is to be done, is it in your power to form a correct judgment upon those, who are advising you correctly or not. Now this would be a state not less shocking than that. If then neither the meeting nor the (single) adviser is able to make you competent to give a judgment, what need is there to you for voting? Or how is this meeting of yours not opposed to your votes, and the vote to the eagerness of those advising you? For this meeting of yours is that of persons not competent, but in need of advisers; while the votes are given as of persons not wanting advisers, but able to form a judgment, and to advise; and the eagerness of those advising you, is as of persons who know; but the votes are given by you, as if the persons advising did not know. Now if any one were to ask you, who have voted, and the person advising you, respecting the matters on which you have voted — do you know

what will that be, for the sake of which you think of doing what you have voted? you would not, I think, be able to say. And even if that should take place, for the sake of which you have it in your thoughts to do every thing, do you know how it will benefit you? I think that neither you nor the party advising you would be able to tell this. But you conceive that some of those with intellect know somehow this. But if a person should ask you who is the party, I do not think you would agree on this point. When therefore both the things, about which you are consulting, are such as not to be manifest, and the persons likewise, who vote and advise, are unskilled, reasonably will you say that it often falls out that persons have no faith in, and repent of, those things, for which they have taken counsel and voted. Now such events it is not becoming to fall out to the sensible. For they know the things, about which they give advice, both of what kind they are, and that they exist firmly to the parties persuaded, for the sake of whom they give the advice, and that neither to themselves nor to the parties persuaded will there be a repentance for any thing senseless. On matters then of this kind I conceive that those, who possess any sense, should think it fit to give advice; but not about the matters on which you are requesting me to advise; for from their advice the result is good fortune, but from the trifling of these misfortune.

I was once present with a person while he was admonishing his friend, because the latter had trusted to an accuser, not having heard the other party making an apology for himself, but hearing only the accuser. He said that (the friend) had done a terrible thing, in deciding against the party without having been present himself, or having heard from the friends of the party, to whose statements it was reasonable for him to trust. For, after having heard both, he would not have so hastily trusted to the accuser; but that it was just, before conferring praise or blame, to hear the party make his defence, as well as

the accuser. · For how could any one decide correctly a suit, or judge in a proper manner between persons, without hearing the opposite parties? for that it is better that assertions, like a purple colour and gold-money, should be judged of by being placed side by side. Or for what purpose has time been allowed to both the opposite parties in a suit? or the judges sworn to hear both sides equally? unless the lawgiver conceived that suits would be decided more justly and better by the judges. But you seem to me to have not even heard of what is said by the multitude. What is it? said (the other).

Decide no suit, till both accounts you've heard.

And yet this would not have been thus circulated, if it had not been well said, and as is fitting. I advise you therefore, said he, for the future not to blame or praise persons so hastily. The other then said that it appeared to him an absurd thing, if it were impossible to know, when one person was speaking, whether he was telling the truth or a falsehood, and yet possible to know, when two persons were speaking; and impossible to learn from a person, when telling the truth, but possible to be taught by that very person and another, when telling a falsehood; and if one by speaking straightforwardly and truly should be unable to show what he is saying clearly, but that two, one of whom should tell a falsehood, and not speak straightforwardly, should be able to show clearly that, which the party speaking straightforwardly was not able to show clearly. And I am at a loss, said he; on this point likewise, how they are to show it clearly; whether by being silent, or speaking. For if they are to show it clearly by being silent, there would be a need of hearing neither, much less both. But if by speaking both are to show it clearly, and both parties speak according to no regular manner and time — for both think they have a right to speak in turn — how is it possible for both to show the matter clearly? For if both are showing the matter clearly at the same

time, both will be speaking together at the same time. But this they are not wont to do, nor do the laws permit it; so that if they are to show the matter clearly by speaking, each of them will do so by speaking; and when either party speaks, then either party will show the matter clearly; so that they will speak one before and the other after; and they will show the matter clearly, one before and the other after. Now if each party in turn shows the same matter clearly, what need is there to hear the latter? for the matter will have become clear by the party first speaking. But if both parties show clearly that matter, said he, how will not either of them have done so? for how would both be able to show clearly that, which one of them shall not have done so? But if either shall have shown it clearly, it is evident that the former will have spoken of it, and the former will have shown it clearly; so that how is it not possible for the person hearing him alone to know all correctly? On hearing them I was at a loss, and unable to decide. For the others, who were present, said that the first reasoning was true. If then you can advise me on this matter, whether it is possible, when one person is saying any thing, to know correctly what he is saying, say so; or whether there is need of a speaker on the opposite side, if a person would know which is speaking straightforwardly. Or whether it is not necessary to hear both parties? Or how do you think?

The day before yesterday a person was finding fault with another, because he was unwilling to lend money or to trust him; and the party, with whom he was finding fault, was defending himself; whereupon another person amongst those, who were present, inquired of the party finding fault – whether he, who had not trusted nor lent the money, had erred? and have not you too, said he, who did not persuade him to lend, erred? In what, said the other party, have I erred? Which of the two, said (the inquirer), seems to you to err? the person, who fails in what he wishes, or he, who does not (fail)? The person

who fails, said he. Have you then not failed in wishing to borrow; while he, who did not wish to give up (his money), has not failed in that point. Truly so, said he; but in what have I erred, even if he has not given it me? Because, said (the inquirer), if you have begged the things which you ought not, how do you think that you have not erred? while he has acted correctly in not giving them up; but if, on the other hand, you have begged what you ought, and failed in this point, how have you not of necessity erred? Perhaps so, said he; but how has he not erred, who did not trust me? If you had treated with him, said (the inquirer), as was fitting, you would not have erred at all. Not at all. But now you have not treated with him, as was fitting. I appear so, said he.” If then he was not persuaded, when you were treating with him, as was not fitting, how can you justly find fault with him? I am unable to say. Nor can you say that one must not pay attention to those, who conduct themselves ill? This (I can say) very much, said he. Do not then those persons seem to you to conduct themselves ill, who treat with a party in a manner that is not fitting? To me at least (they seem so), said he. In what then did he err, if he paid no attention to you, when conducting yourself ill? It appears, said he, in nothing. Why then, said (the inquirer), do persons find fault on such matters with each other, and blame those, who are not persuaded by them, because they are not persuaded, but do not find fault with themselves at all, because they have not persuaded them? Hereupon another party who was present, observed — When a person has conducted himself well towards any one, and has assisted him, and subsequently requests that party to conduct himself in a similar manner towards him, but does not meet with such conduct, how does he not reasonably find fault? Is not, said (the inquirer), the person whom the party requests to conduct himself in a similar manner, either able to conduct himself well, or unable? (Yes.) And if he is unable, how can he properly make the request, who requests him (to

perform) what he cannot? but if he is able, how did he not persuade him (to do so)? or how do persons, who speak in this way, speak correctly? But, said (the other), it is requisite, by Zeus, to find fault with such a person, in order that both he may for the remainder of his life conduct himself better, and the other mean fellows, who hear the party finding fault. Think you, said (the inquirer), that any persons will conduct themselves better when they hear a party speaking correctly, or when in error? When speaking correctly, said he. Now the party, who was speaking not correctly, did not seem to you to make a request correctly? Truly so, said he. How then will those, who hear a person finding fault in this way, conduct themselves better. Not at all, said he. For what purpose, then, would a person find fault in this way? He confessed lie could not discover. Some one was accusing a person of stupidity, because lie had given credence quickly even to parties he happened to meet with, while they were speaking. To fellow-citizens and familiar friends, when speaking, it is reasonable to trust. But to persons of that kind, whom he had never seen nor heard of before, to give credence, and this too when he was not ignorant that the majority of men are braggarts and knaves, was no little proof of silliness. When one of those present observed — For my part I thought that you considered a person of greater value, who could quickly understand even any one he met with, rather than him, who did so slowly. And so I do consider, said the other. Why then, said (the former), do you find fault, if a person gives credence quickly, even to those he meets with, when they speak the truth? But, said (the other), I do not find fault with this, but because he gives credence to those, who tell falsehoods. But, if after a longer period even to those not accidentally met with he had given credence, and suffered annoyance, would you not have found fault with him still more? Yes; I should have done so, said he. Is it, because he gave credence slowly, even to those not accidentally met with? No,

by Zeus, said he. For I suppose, said the other, you do not conceive that it is right to find fault with a person on this account, but because he gives credence to those, who state what is not credible. I do so, said he. Whether then, said (the other), do you think it is not right to find fault with him for giving credence slowly even to those not accidentally met with, but right (to do so) for giving credence quickly even to those accidentally met with? Not I indeed, said he. Why then do you find fault with him? said (the other). Because he errs in giving credence to persons accidentally met with, previous to making an inquiry. But if he had slowly given credence, previous to making an inquiry, he would not have erred. Not so, by Zeus, said he; but he would have erred even thus not the less; but I think one ought not to give credence to persons accidentally met with. But if, said (the other), you think one ought not to give credence to persons accidentally met with, how is it fitting to give credence quickly to persons unknown? and do you think that it is requisite to make an inquiry, whether they are speaking the truth? I think so, said he. Say then, said (the other), is it not requisite to make inquiry about familiar friends and acquaintances, whether they are speaking the truth? I should say so, said he. For perhaps, said (the other), some of these state what is not credible. And very much so, said he. Why then, said (the other), is it more reasonable to give credence to familiar friends and acquaintances than to persons accidentally met with? I cannot tell, said he. What then, if it is requisite (not) to give more credence to familiar friends than to persons accidentally met with, is it not requisite to consider them less trustworthy than persons accidentally met with? How not? said he. If then there are familiar friends to some persons, and persons unknown to others, how will it not be necessary to consider the same persons more trustworthy than the same? For it is requisite to consider familiar friends and persons unknown, as not equally trustworthy, as you say yourself. This

does not please me, said he. Equally, said (the former), do. some believe what is stated by them, but others disbelieve? And. this too is strange, said he. If then, said (the other), both familiar friends and persons accidentally met with state the same things, would not all things stated equally to all be credible or incredible (equally)? Necessarily so, said he. Must we not give credence then equally to those who state the same things? It is probable, said he.

On their conversing in this way, I was at a loss to whom one ought to give credence and to whom not, and whether to the trust-worthy and those who know what they are speaking about, or to familiar friends and acquaintances. Upon these matters then how think you?

Eryxias

ΕΡΥΞΙΑΣ

Plato

translated by Benjamin Jowett

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It happened by chance that Eryxias the Steirian was walking with me in the Portico of Zeus the Deliverer, when there came up to us Critias and Erasistratus, the latter the son of Phaeax, who was the nephew of Erasistratus. Now Erasistratus had just arrived from Sicily and that part of the world. As they approached, he said, Hail, Socrates!

Socrates: The same to you, I said; have you any good news from Sicily to tell us?

Erasistratus: Most excellent. But, if you please, let us first sit down; for I am tired with my yesterday's journey from Megara.

Socrates: Gladly, if that is your desire.

Erasistratus: What would you wish to hear first? he said. What the Sicilians are doing, or how they are disposed towards our city? To my mind, they are very like wasps: so long as you only cause them a little annoyance they are quite unmanageable; you must destroy their nests if you wish to get the better of them. And in a similar way, the Syracusans, unless we set to work in earnest, and go against them with a great expedition, will never submit to our rule. The petty injuries which we at present inflict merely irritate them enough to make them utterly intractable. And now they have sent ambassadors to Athens, and intend, I suspect, to play us some trick. — While we were talking, the Syracusan envoys chanced to go by, and Erasistratus, pointing to one of them, said to me, That, Socrates, is the richest man in all Italy and Sicily. For who has larger estates or more land at his disposal to cultivate if he please? And they are of a quality, too, finer than any other land in Hellas. Moreover, he has all the things which go to make up wealth, slaves and horses innumerable, gold and silver without end.

I saw that he was inclined to expatiate on the riches of the man; so I asked him, Well, Erasistratus, and what sort of character does he bear in Sicily?

Erasistratus: He is esteemed to be, and really is, the wickedest of all the Sicilians and Italians, and even more wicked than he is rich; indeed, if you were to ask any Sicilian whom he thought to be the worst and the richest of mankind, you would never hear any one else named.

I reflected that we were speaking, not of trivial matters, but about wealth and virtue, which are deemed to be of the greatest moment, and I asked Erasistratus whom he considered the wealthier, — he who was the possessor of a talent of silver or he who had a field worth two talents?

Erasistratus: The owner of the field.

Socrates: And on the same principle he who had robes and bedding and such things which are of greater value to him than to a stranger would be richer than the stranger?

Erasistratus: True.

Socrates: And if any one gave you a choice, which of these would you prefer?

Erasistratus: That which was most valuable.

Socrates: In which way do you think you would be the richer?

Erasistratus: By choosing as I said.

Socrates: And he appears to you to be the richest who has goods of the greatest value?

Erasistratus: He does.

Socrates: And are not the healthy richer than the sick, since health is a possession more valuable than riches to the sick? Surely there is no one who would not prefer to be poor and well, rather than to have all the King of Persia's wealth and to be ill. And this proves that men set health above wealth, else they would never choose the one in preference to the other.

Erasistratus: True.

Socrates: And if anything appeared to be more valuable than health, he would be the richest who possessed it?

Erasistratus: He would.

Socrates: Suppose that some one came to us at this moment and were to ask, Well, Socrates and Eryxias and Erasistratus, can you tell me what is of the greatest value to men? Is it not that of which the possession will best enable a man to advise how his own and his friend's affairs should be administered? — What will be our reply?

Erasistratus: I should say, Socrates, that happiness was the most precious of human possessions.

Socrates: Not a bad answer. But do we not deem those men who are most prosperous to be the happiest?

Erasistratus: That is my opinion.

Socrates: And are they not most prosperous who commit the fewest errors in respect either of themselves or of other men?

Erasistratus: Certainly.

Socrates: And they who know what is evil and what is good; what should be done and what should be left undone; — these behave the most wisely and make the fewest mistakes?

Erasistratus agreed to this.

Socrates: Then the wisest and those who do best and the most fortunate and the richest would appear to be all one and the same, if wisdom is really the most valuable of our possessions?

Yes, said Eryxias, interposing, but what use would it be if a man had the wisdom of Nestor and wanted the necessities of life, food and drink and clothes and the like? Where would be the advantage of wisdom then? Or how could he be the richest of

men who might even have to go begging, because he had not wherewithal to live?

I thought that what Eryxias was saying had some weight, and I replied, Would the wise man really suffer in this way, if he were so ill-provided; whereas if he had the house of Polytion, and the house were full of gold and silver, he would lack nothing?

Eryxias: Yes; for then he might dispose of his property and obtain in exchange what he needed, or he might sell it for money with which he could supply his wants and in a moment procure abundance of everything.

Socrates: True, if he could find some one who preferred such a house to the wisdom of Nestor. But if there are persons who set great store by wisdom like Nestor's and the advantages accruing from it, to sell these, if he were so disposed, would be easier still. Or is a house a most useful and necessary possession, and does it make a great difference in the comfort of life to have a mansion like Polytion's instead of living in a shabby little cottage, whereas wisdom is of small use and it is of no importance whether a man is wise or ignorant about the highest matters? Or is wisdom despised of men and can find no buyers, although cypress wood and marble of Pentelicus are eagerly bought by numerous purchasers? Surely the prudent pilot or the skilful physician, or the artist of any kind who is proficient in his art, is more worth than the things which are especially reckoned among riches; and he who can advise well and prudently for himself and others is able also to sell the product of his art, if he so desire.

Eryxias looked askance, as if he had received some unfair treatment, and said, I believe, Socrates, that if you were forced to speak the truth, you would declare that you were richer than Callias the son of Hipponicus. And yet, although you claimed to be wiser about things of real importance, you would not any the

more be richer than he.

I dare say, Eryxias, I said, that you may regard these arguments of ours as a kind of game; you think that they have no relation to facts, but are like the pieces in the game of draughts which the player can move in such a way that his opponents are unable to make any countermove. (Compare Republic.) And perhaps, too, as regards riches you are of opinion that while facts remain the same, there are arguments, no matter whether true or false, which enable the user of them to prove that the wisest and the richest are one and the same, although he is in the wrong and his opponents are in the right. There would be nothing strange in this; it would be as if two persons were to dispute about letters, one declaring that the word Socrates began with an S, the other that it began with an A, and the latter could gain the victory over the former.

Eryxias glanced at the audience, laughing and blushing at once, as if he had had nothing to do with what had just been said, and replied, — No, indeed, Socrates, I never supposed that our arguments should be of a kind which would never convince any one of those here present or be of advantage to them. For what man of sense could ever be persuaded that the wisest and the richest are the same? The truth is that we are discussing the subject of riches, and my notion is that we should argue respecting the honest and dishonest means of acquiring them, and, generally, whether they are a good thing or a bad.

Very good, I said, and I am obliged to you for the hint: in future we will be more careful. But why do not you yourself, as you introduced the argument, and do not think that the former discussion touched the point at issue, tell us whether you consider riches to be a good or an evil?

I am of opinion, he said, that they are a good. He was about to add something more, when Critias interrupted him: — Do you

really suppose so, Eryxias?

Certainly, replied Eryxias; I should be mad if I did not: and I do not fancy that you would find any one else of a contrary opinion.

And I, retorted Critias, should say that there is no one whom I could not compel to admit that riches are bad for some men. But surely, if they were a good, they could not appear bad for any one?

Here I interposed and said to them: If you two were having an argument about equitation and what was the best way of riding, supposing that I knew the art myself, I should try to bring you to an agreement. For I should be ashamed if I were present and did not do what I could to prevent your difference. And I should do the same if you were quarrelling about any other art and were likely, unless you agreed on the point in dispute, to part as enemies instead of as friends. But now, when we are contending about a thing of which the usefulness continues during the whole of life, and it makes an enormous difference whether we are to regard it as beneficial or not, — a thing, too, which is esteemed of the highest importance by the Hellenes: — (for parents, as soon as their children are, as they think, come to years of discretion, urge them to consider how wealth may be acquired, since by riches the value of a man is judged): — When, I say, we are thus in earnest, and you, who agree in other respects, fall to disputing about a matter of such moment, that is, about wealth, and not merely whether it is black or white, light or heavy, but whether it is a good or an evil, whereby, although you are now the dearest of friends and kinsmen, the most bitter hatred may arise betwixt you, I must hinder your dissension to the best of my power. If I could, I would tell you the truth, and so put an end to the dispute; but as I cannot do this, and each of you supposes that you can bring the other to an agreement, I am prepared, as far as my capacity admits, to

help you in solving the question. Please, therefore, Critias, try to make us accept the doctrines which you yourself entertain.

Critias: I should like to follow up the argument, and will ask Eryxias whether he thinks that there are just and unjust men?

Eryxias: Most decidedly.

Critias: And does injustice seem to you an evil or a good?

Eryxias: An evil.

Critias: Do you consider that he who bribes his neighbour's wife and commits adultery with her, acts justly or unjustly, and this although both the state and the laws forbid?

Eryxias: Unjustly.

Critias: And if the wicked man has wealth and is willing to spend it, he will carry out his evil purposes? whereas he who is short of means cannot do what he fain would, and therefore does not sin? In such a case, surely, it is better that a person should not be wealthy, if his poverty prevents the accomplishment of his desires, and his desires are evil? Or, again, should you call sickness a good or an evil?

Eryxias: An evil.

Critias: Well, and do you think that some men are intemperate?

Eryxias: Yes.

Critias: Then, if it is better for his health that the intemperate man should refrain from meat and drink and other pleasant things, but he cannot owing to his intemperance, will it not also be better that he should be too poor to gratify his lust rather than that he should have a superabundance of means? For thus he will not be able to sin, although he desire never so much.

Critias appeared to be arguing so admirably that Eryxias, if he had not been ashamed of the bystanders, would probably have

got up and struck him. For he thought that he had been robbed of a great possession when it became obvious to him that he had been wrong in his former opinion about wealth. I observed his vexation, and feared that they would proceed to abuse and quarrelling: so I said, — I heard that very argument used in the Lyceum yesterday by a wise man, Prodicus of Ceos; but the audience thought that he was talking mere nonsense, and no one could be persuaded that he was speaking the truth. And when at last a certain talkative young gentleman came in, and, taking his seat, began to laugh and jeer at Prodicus, tormenting him and demanding an explanation of his argument, he gained the ear of the audience far more than Prodicus.

Can you repeat the discourse to us? Said Erasistratus.

Socrates: If I can only remember it, I will. The youth began by asking Prodicus, In what way did he think that riches were a good and in what an evil? Prodicus answered, as you did just now, that they were a good to good men and to those who knew in what way they should be employed, while to the bad and the ignorant they were an evil. The same is true, he went on to say, of all other things; men make them to be what they are themselves. The saying of Archilochus is true: — ‘Men’s thoughts correspond to the things which they meet with.’

Well, then, replied the youth, if any one makes me wise in that wisdom whereby good men become wise, he must also make everything else good to me. Not that he concerns himself at all with these other things, but he has converted my ignorance into wisdom. If, for example, a person teach me grammar or music, he will at the same time teach me all that relates to grammar or music, and so when he makes me good, he makes things good to me.

Prodicus did not altogether agree: still he consented to what was said.

And do you think, said the youth, that doing good things is like building a house, — the work of human agency; or do things remain what they were at first, good or bad, for all time?

Prodicus began to suspect, I fancy, the direction which the argument was likely to take, and did not wish to be put down by a mere stripling before all those present: — (if they two had been alone, he would not have minded): — so he answered, cleverly enough: I think that doing good things is a work of human agency.

And is virtue in your opinion, Prodicus, innate or acquired by instruction?

The latter, said Prodicus.

Then you would consider him a simpleton who supposed that he could obtain by praying to the Gods the knowledge of grammar or music or any other art, which he must either learn from another or find out for himself?

Prodicus agreed to this also.

And when you pray to the Gods that you may do well and receive good, you mean by your prayer nothing else than that you desire to become good and wise: — if, at least, things are good to the good and wise and evil to the evil. But in that case, if virtue is acquired by instruction, it would appear that you only pray to be taught what you do not know.

Hereupon I said to Prodicus that it was no misfortune to him if he had been proved to be in error in supposing that the Gods immediately granted to us whatever we asked: — if, I added, whenever you go up to the Acropolis you earnestly entreat the Gods to grant you good things, although you know not whether they can yield your request, it is as though you went to the doors of the grammarian and begged him, although you had never made a study of the art, to give you a knowledge of

grammar which would enable you forthwith to do the business of a grammarian.

While I was speaking, Prodicus was preparing to retaliate upon his youthful assailant, intending to employ the argument of which you have just made use; for he was annoyed to have it supposed that he offered a vain prayer to the Gods. But the master of the gymnasium came to him and begged him to leave because he was teaching the youths doctrines which were unsuited to them, and therefore bad for them.

I have told you this because I want you to understand how men are circumstanced in regard to philosophy. Had Prodicus been present and said what you have said, the audience would have thought him raving, and he would have been ejected from the gymnasium. But you have argued so excellently well that you have not only persuaded your hearers, but have brought your opponent to an agreement. For just as in the law courts, if two witnesses testify to the same fact, one of whom seems to be an honest fellow and the other a rogue, the testimony of the rogue often has the contrary effect on the judges' minds to what he intended, while the same evidence if given by the honest man at once strikes them as perfectly true. And probably the audience have something of the same feeling about yourself and Prodicus; they think him a Sophist and a braggart, and regard you as a gentleman of courtesy and worth. For they do not pay attention to the argument so much as to the character of the speaker.

But truly, Socrates, said Erasistratus, though you may be joking, Critias does seem to me to be saying something which is of weight.

Socrates: I am in profound earnest, I assure you. But why, as you have begun your argument so prettily, do you not go on with the rest? There is still something lacking, now you have

agreed that (wealth) is a good to some and an evil to others. It remains to enquire what constitutes wealth; for unless you know this, you cannot possibly come to an understanding as to whether it is a good or an evil. I am ready to assist you in the enquiry to the utmost of my power: but first let him who affirms that riches are a good, tell us what, in his opinion, is wealth.

Erasistratus: Indeed, Socrates, I have no notion about wealth beyond that which men commonly have. I suppose that wealth is a quantity of money (compare Arist. Pol.); and this, I imagine, would also be Critias' definition.

Socrates: Then now we have to consider, What is money? Or else later on we shall be found to differ about the question. For instance, the Carthaginians use money of this sort. Something which is about the size of a stater is tied up in a small piece of leather: what it is, no one knows but the makers. A seal is next set upon the leather, which then passes into circulation, and he who has the largest number of such pieces is esteemed the richest and best off. And yet if any one among us had a mass of such coins he would be no wealthier than if he had so many pebbles from the mountain. At Lacedaemon, again, they use iron by weight which has been rendered useless: and he who has the greatest mass of such iron is thought to be the richest, although elsewhere it has no value. In Ethiopia engraved stones are employed, of which a Lacedaemonian could make no use. Once more, among the Nomad Scythians a man who owned the house of Polytion would not be thought richer than one who possessed Mount Lycabettus among ourselves. And clearly those things cannot all be regarded as possessions; for in some cases the possessors would appear none the richer thereby: but, as I was saying, some one of them is thought in one place to be money, and the possessors of it are the wealthy, whereas in some other place it is not money, and the ownership of it does not confer wealth; just as the standard of morals varies, and

what is honourable to some men is dishonourable to others. And if we wish to enquire why a house is valuable to us but not to the Scythians, or why the Carthaginians value leather which is worthless to us, or the Lacedaemonians find wealth in iron and we do not, can we not get an answer in some such way as this: Would an Athenian, who had a thousand talents weight of the stones which lie about in the Agora and which we do not employ for any purpose, be thought to be any the richer?

Erasistratus: He certainly would not appear so to me.

Socrates: But if he possessed a thousand talents weight of some precious stone, we should say that he was very rich?

Erasistratus: Of course.

Socrates: The reason is that the one is useless and the other useful?

Erasistratus: Yes.

Socrates: And in the same way among the Scythians a house has no value because they have no use for a house, nor would a Scythian set so much store on the finest house in the world as on a leather coat, because he could use the one and not the other. Or again, the Carthaginian coinage is not wealth in our eyes, for we could not employ it, as we can silver, to procure what we need, and therefore it is of no use to us.

Erasistratus: True.

Socrates: What is useful to us, then, is wealth, and what is useless to us is not wealth?

But how do you mean, Socrates? said Eryxias, interrupting. Do we not employ in our intercourse with one another speech and violence (?) and various other things? These are useful and yet they are not wealth.

Socrates: Clearly we have not yet answered the question, What is wealth? That wealth must be useful, to be wealth at all, — thus much is acknowledged by every one. But what particular thing is wealth, if not all things? Let us pursue the argument in another way; and then we may perhaps find what we are seeking. What is the use of wealth, and for what purpose has the possession of riches been invented, — in the sense, I mean, in which drugs have been discovered for the cure of disease? Perhaps in this way we may throw some light on the question. It appears to be clear that whatever constitutes wealth must be useful, and that wealth is one class of useful things; and now we have to enquire, What is the use of those useful things which constitute wealth? For all things probably may be said to be useful which we use in production, just as all things which have life are animals, but there is a special kind of animal which we call ‘man.’ Now if any one were to ask us, What is that of which, if we were rid, we should not want medicine and the instruments of medicine, we might reply that this would be the case if disease were absent from our bodies and either never came to them at all or went away again as soon as it appeared; and we may therefore conclude that medicine is the science which is useful for getting rid of disease. But if we are further asked, What is that from which, if we were free, we should have no need of wealth? can we give an answer? If we have none, suppose that we restate the question thus: — If a man could live without food or drink, and yet suffer neither hunger nor thirst, would he want either money or anything else in order to supply his needs?

Eryxias: He would not.

Socrates: And does not this apply in other cases? If we did not want for the service of the body the things of which we now stand in need, and heat and cold and the other bodily sensations were unperceived by us, there would be no use in this so-called

wealth, if no one, that is, had any necessity for those things which now make us wish for wealth in order that we may satisfy the desires and needs of the body in respect of our various wants. And therefore if the possession of wealth is useful in ministering to our bodily wants, and bodily wants were unknown to us, we should not need wealth, and possibly there would be no such thing as wealth.

Eryxias: Clearly not.

Socrates: Then our conclusion is, as would appear, that wealth is what is useful to this end?

Eryxias once more gave his assent, but the small argument considerably troubled him.

Socrates: And what is your opinion about another question: — Would you say that the same thing can be at one time useful and at another useless for the production of the same result?

Eryxias: I cannot say more than that if we require the same thing to produce the same result, then it seems to me to be useful; if not, not.

Socrates: Then if without the aid of fire we could make a brazen statue, we should not want fire for that purpose; and if we did not want it, it would be useless to us? And the argument applies equally in other cases.

Eryxias: Clearly.

Socrates: And therefore conditions which are not required for the existence of a thing are not useful for the production of it?

Eryxias: Of course not.

Socrates: And if without gold or silver or anything else which we do not use directly for the body in the way that we do food and drink and bedding and houses, — if without these we could satisfy the wants of the body, they would be of no use to us for

that purpose?

Eryxias: They would not.

Socrates: They would no longer be regarded as wealth, because they are useless, whereas that would be wealth which enabled us to obtain what was useful to us?

Eryxias: O Socrates, you will never be able to persuade me that gold and silver and similar things are not wealth. But I am very strongly of opinion that things which are useless to us are not wealth, and that the money which is useful for this purpose is of the greatest use; not that these things are not useful towards life, if by them we can procure wealth.

Socrates: And how would you answer another question? There are persons, are there not, who teach music and grammar and other arts for pay, and thus procure those things of which they stand in need?

Eryxias: There are.

Socrates: And these men by the arts which they profess, and in exchange for them, obtain the necessities of life just as we do by means of gold and silver?

Eryxias: True.

Socrates: Then if they procure by this means what they want for the purposes of life, that art will be useful towards life? For do we not say that silver is useful because it enables us to supply our bodily needs?

Eryxias: We do.

Socrates: Then if these arts are reckoned among things useful, the arts are wealth for the same reason as gold and silver are, for, clearly, the possession of them gives wealth. Yet a little while ago we found it difficult to accept the argument which proved that the wisest are the wealthiest. But now there seems

no escape from this conclusion. Suppose that we are asked, 'Is a horse useful to everybody?' will not our reply be, 'No, but only to those who know how to use a horse?'

Eryxias: Certainly.

Socrates: And so, too, physic is not useful to every one, but only to him who knows how to use it?

Eryxias: True.

Socrates: And the same is the case with everything else?

Eryxias: Yes.

Socrates: Then gold and silver and all the other elements which are supposed to make up wealth are only useful to the person who knows how to use them?

Eryxias: Exactly.

Socrates: And were we not saying before that it was the business of a good man and a gentleman to know where and how anything should be used?

Eryxias: Yes.

Socrates: The good and gentle, therefore will alone have profit from these things, supposing at least that they know how to use them. But if so, to them only will they seem to be wealth. It appears, however, that where a person is ignorant of riding, and has horses which are useless to him, if some one teaches him that art, he makes him also richer, for what was before useless has now become useful to him, and in giving him knowledge he has also conferred riches upon him.

Eryxias: That is the case.

Socrates: Yet I dare be sworn that Critias will not be moved a whit by the argument.

Critias: No, by heaven, I should be a madman if I were. But why do you not finish the argument which proves that gold and silver and other things which seem to be wealth are not real wealth? For I have been exceedingly delighted to hear the discourses which you have just been holding.

Socrates: My argument, Critias (I said), appears to have given you the same kind of pleasure which you might have derived from some rhapsode's recitation of Homer; for you do not believe a word of what has been said. But come now, give me an answer to this question. Are not certain things useful to the builder when he is building a house?

Critias: They are.

Socrates: And would you say that those things are useful which are employed in house building, — stones and bricks and beams and the like, and also the instruments with which the builder built the house, the beams and stones which they provided, and again the instruments by which these were obtained?

Critias: It seems to me that they are all useful for building.

Socrates: And is it not true of every art, that not only the materials but the instruments by which we procure them and without which the work could not go on, are useful for that art?

Critias: Certainly.

Socrates: And further, the instruments by which the instruments are procured, and so on, going back from stage to stage ad infinitum, — are not all these, in your opinion, necessary in order to carry out the work?

Critias: We may fairly suppose such to be the case.

Socrates: And if a man has food and drink and clothes and the other things which are useful to the body, would he need gold or silver or any other means by which he could procure that

which he now has?

Critias: I do not think so.

Socrates: Then you consider that a man never wants any of these things for the use of the body?

Critias: Certainly not.

Socrates: And if they appear useless to this end, ought they not always to appear useless? For we have already laid down the principle that things cannot be at one time useful and at another time not, in the same process.

Critias: But in that respect your argument and mine are the same. For you maintain if they are useful to a certain end, they can never become useless; whereas I say that in order to accomplish some results bad things are needed, and good for others.

Socrates: But can a bad thing be used to carry out a good purpose?

Critias: I should say not.

Socrates: And we call those actions good which a man does for the sake of virtue?

Critias: Yes.

Socrates: But can a man learn any kind of knowledge which is imparted by word of mouth if he is wholly deprived of the sense of hearing?

Critias: Certainly not, I think.

Socrates: And will not hearing be useful for virtue, if virtue is taught by hearing and we use the sense of hearing in giving instruction?

Critias: Yes.

Socrates: And since medicine frees the sick man from his disease, that art too may sometimes appear useful in the acquisition of virtue, e.g. when hearing is procured by the aid of medicine.

Critias: Very likely.

Socrates: But if, again, we obtain by wealth the aid of medicine, shall we not regard wealth as useful for virtue?

Critias: True.

Socrates: And also the instruments by which wealth is procured?

Critias: Certainly.

Socrates: Then you think that a man may gain wealth by bad and disgraceful means, and, having obtained the aid of medicine which enables him to acquire the power of hearing, may use that very faculty for the acquisition of virtue?

Critias: Yes, I do.

Socrates: But can that which is evil be useful for virtue?

Critias: No.

Socrates: It is not therefore necessary that the means by which we obtain what is useful for a certain object should always be useful for the same object: for it seems that bad actions may sometimes serve good purposes? The matter will be still plainer if we look at it in this way: — If things are useful towards the several ends for which they exist, which ends would not come into existence without them, how would you regard them? Can ignorance, for instance, be useful for knowledge, or disease for health, or vice for virtue?

Critias: Never.

Socrates: And yet we have already agreed — have we not? — that there can be no knowledge where there has not previously been ignorance, nor health where there has not been disease, nor virtue where there has not been vice?

Critias: I think that we have.

Socrates: But then it would seem that the antecedents without which a thing cannot exist are not necessarily useful to it. Otherwise ignorance would appear useful for knowledge, disease for health, and vice for virtue.

Critias still showed great reluctance to accept any argument which went to prove that all these things were useless. I saw that it was as difficult to persuade him as (according to the proverb) it is to boil a stone, so I said: Let us bid 'good-bye' to the discussion, since we cannot agree whether these things are useful and a part of wealth or not. But what shall we say to another question: Which is the happier and better man, — he who requires the greatest quantity of necessities for body and diet, or he who requires only the fewest and least? The answer will perhaps become more obvious if we suppose some one, comparing the man himself at different times, to consider whether his condition is better when he is sick or when he is well?

Critias: That is not a question which needs much consideration.

Socrates: Probably, I said, every one can understand that health is a better condition than disease. But when have we the greatest and the most various needs, when we are sick or when we are well?

Critias: When we are sick.

Socrates: And when we are in the worst state we have the greatest and most especial need and desire of bodily pleasures?

Critias: True.

Socrates: And seeing that a man is best off when he is least in need of such things, does not the same reasoning apply to the case of any two persons, of whom one has many and great wants and desires, and the other few and moderate? For instance, some men are gamblers, some drunkards, and some gluttons: and gambling and the love of drink and greediness are all desires?

Critias: Certainly.

Socrates: But desires are only the lack of something: and those who have the greatest desires are in a worse condition than those who have none or very slight ones?

Critias: Certainly I consider that those who have such wants are bad, and that the greater their wants the worse they are.

Socrates: And do we think it possible that a thing should be useful for a purpose unless we have need of it for that purpose?

Critias: No.

Socrates: Then if these things are useful for supplying the needs of the body, we must want them for that purpose?

Critias: That is my opinion.

Socrates: And he to whom the greatest number of things are useful for his purpose, will also want the greatest number of means of accomplishing it, supposing that we necessarily feel the want of all useful things?

Critias: It seems so.

Socrates: The argument proves then that he who has great riches has likewise need of many things for the supply of the wants of the body; for wealth appears useful towards that end. And the richest must be in the worst condition, since they seem to be most in want of such things.

On Justice

ΠΕΡΙ ΔΙΚΑΙΟΥ

Plato

translated by George Burges

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Can you tell us what is justice? or does it seem to you not worth entering into a discourse about it? To me at least (it seems) very much so. What is it then? What else than the things considered just. Do not (speak)' to me in this way; but, as if you had asked me — What is the eye? I should have said to you — It is that, by which we see; and if you should bid me to prove it, I would prove it. And if you should ask — To what is given the name of soul? I would say — To that, by which we know (something). And if again — What is the voice? I would answer — That, by which we converse. In this way then do you tell me that justice is that, which we use for something, as are the things, of which I was just now asking. I have it not in my power to reply in this way at all. But, since such is the case, perhaps we shall discover it more easily in this way. Come then, (say,) by what do we, on consideration, distinguish the greater and the less? Is it not by a measure? Yes. And together with a measure by what art? Is it not by that of measurement? Yes. And how things light and heavy? Is it not by weight? Yes. And together with a weight by what art? Is it not that of weighing? Certainly. Well then, by what instrument do we, on consideration, distinguish what is just and unjust? and together with the instrument, by what art previously? Is it not somehow manifest to you thus? No. But (let us consider it) again in this way. When we are disputing about things greater and less, who decides between us? Is it not the measurers? Yes. And when about things many and few, who are the persons to decide? Is it not the numberers? But what, when we are disputing with each other about things just and unjust, to whom do we come? and who are the persons to decide on each occasion between us? Say. Do you not, Socrates, mean the judges? You have correctly made the discovery. Come then and try to tell this likewise. By doing what do the measurers decide respecting things large and small? Is it not by measuring? Yes. And respecting things heavy and light? Is it not by weighing? Yes. And respecting things many and few? Is it not

by numbering? Yes. But how, respecting things just and unjust? Answer me. I cannot say. Say, by speaking. Yes. By speaking then do judges decide between us, when they are forming a judgment respecting things just and unjust. Yes. And by measuring, those skilled in measuring things small and great? for a measure is that, by which these things are judged. It is so. And by weighing, those skilled in weighing things heavy and light? for a weight is that, by which these things are judged. Yes, it is. And again by numbering, those skilled in numbering things many and few? for number is that by which these things are judged. It is so. But by speaking, as we just now agreed, the judges decide respecting things just and unjust. You speak correctly, Socrates. It is true then; and speech is that, it seems, by which things just and unjust are judged. What then are things just and unjust? As if a person had asked us — Since a measure, and the measuring art, and the person skilled in measuring, decide which is the greater and the less, what is the greater and the less? Shall we say to him that the greater exceeds, and the less is exceeded? and since a weight and the weighing art and the person skilled in weighing decide the heavy and the light, shall we say to him, that the thing going downwards in the scales is heavy, but the thing (going) upwards is light? In like manner if he should ask us — Since speech and the art of judging and the judge is the party who decides what is just and unjust, -what is the just and unjust? “What answer shall we have to give him? Or have we not a single word to say? We have not. Whether willingly or unwillingly do men, think you, have this injustice? I mean in this way. Think you that they do injustice [and are unjust] willingly or unwillingly? Willingly, I imagine, Socrates; for they are wicked. You conceive then that men are willingly wicked and unjust. I So; and do not you? No; at least if we are to be persuaded by the poet. What kind of poet? He who said — Not one is wicked willingly, nor blest Unwillingly.

But still on the other hand, Socrates, well is the old proverb, that Poets do many falsehoods sing. But I should marvel, if this poet has told a falsehood. Come then, if you are at leisure, let us consider, whether he is saying what is false or true. Nay, I am at leisure. Come then, (say,) do you deem it just to tell a falsehood, or to tell the truth? To tell the truth. To tell a falsehood then is unjust? Yes. But whether to deceive or to not deceive? To not deceive, assuredly. To deceive then is unjust? Yes. But what, is it just to hurt, or to benefit? To benefit. To hurt then is unjust? Yes. It is just then to tell the truth, and to not deceive, and to benefit; but to tell a falsehood, and to hurt, and to deceive, unjust. Yes, by Zeus, and greatly so. What, to do so to enemies? By no means. But it is just to do a hurt to enemies, but to do a benefit, unjust. Yes. It is then just by deceiving enemies to do them a hurt? How not? Well then, to tell a falsehood in order that we may deceive and do a hurt to enemies, is it not just? It is. But what, do you not say that it is just to do a benefit to friends? I do. Whether by not deceiving or by deceiving for their benefit? By deceiving even, by Zeus. But is it just to do a benefit by deceiving, and yet not by telling a falsehood? or by telling a falsehood? It is just by telling even a falsehood. To tell a falsehood and to tell the truth is, as it seems, both just and unjust. Yes. And to not deceive and to deceive is both just and unjust. So it seems. And to do a hurt and to do a benefit is just and unjust. Yes. All things of this kind are it seems the same, both just and unjust. To me at least they appear so. Hear then. I have, like other men, a right eye and a left. Yes. And a right nostril and a left. Certainly. And a right hand and a left. Yes. Hence, since after giving the same name, you say that some of my (members) are on the right side, and others on the left, would you not be able to say, if I asked you, on which side they were, that some on one side are the right, and others on the other side the left? Yes. Come then, likewise, to that point, since after giving the same name, you say that some acts are just, and

some unjust, can you tell which are the just, and which the unjust? To me then it now appears that each of these acts, taking place at a proper time, are just; but at not a proper one, unjust. And correctly does it appear to you. He then, who does each of these acts at a proper time, does what is just; but he, who does not at a proper time, (does) what is unjust. Yes. He then, who does what is just, is just; but he who does what is unjust, is unjust. It is so. Who then at a proper time is able to cut and burn and to make lean? The medical man. Because he knows, or for some other reason? Because he knows. And who (is able) at a proper time to dig, and to plough, and to plant? The land-tiller. Because he knows, or because he does not? Because he knows. And in this way as regards other matters, he who knows, is able to do what is proper at a proper time; but he who does not know, is not. Thus it is. And he who knows how to tell falsehoods, and to deceive, and to do a benefit, is able to do each of these things at a proper time; but he who does not know, is not. You say what is true. And he who does these acts at a fitting time is just. Yes. He does them then through knowledge. How not? The just man then is just through knowledge. Yes. The unjust man then is unjust through what is opposite to what is just. It appears so. Now the just man is just through wisdom. Yes. And the unjust man is unjust through the want of instruction. It seems so. That, which our ancestors left us, as wisdom, seems near to being justice; but that, which (they left) as want of instruction, to be injustice. It is likely. Are men uninstructed willingly, or unwillingly? Unwillingly. Unwillingly then they are unjust. It appears so. But the unjust are wicked. Yes. Unwillingly then persons are wicked and unjust. By all means. But they act unjustly through there being the unjust. Yes. Through an act of unwillingness. Certainly. But that, which is willing, does not take place through what is unwilling. It does not. But the doing of injustice takes place through the existence of injustice. Yes. Now injustice is an involuntary act.

Involuntary. Unwillingly then persons do an injustice, and are unjust and wicked. Unwillingly, as it appears. The poet then did not in this case tell a falsehood. It seems not.

On Virtue

ΠΕΡΙ ΑΡΕΤΗΣ

Plato

translated by George Burges

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Is Virtue a thing to be taught, or to be not taught? but do men become good by nature, or by any other means? I cannot, Socrates, state at present. But let us consider the matter in this way. Come then, (say,) if a person wished to become good in the virtue, in which clever cooks are good, from whence would he become so? It is evident, if he learnt from good cooks. Well then, if a person wished to become a good physician, by going to whom would he become a good physician? It is evident, by going to some one of the good physicians. But if he wished to become good in the art, in which clever carpenters (are good)? To (some one) of the (good) carpenters.

If then he wished to be good in the virtue, in which men are good and clever, whither must he go and learn? I conceive to (some one) of the (good) men (to learn) this, if it is to be learnt; for from whence else? Come then, (say,) who are the men that have become good? in order that we may see whether these are the persons, who make men good, Thucydides, and Themistocles, and Aristides, and Pericles.

Have we it in our power to say who was the teacher of each of these? We have not; for it is not told. Well then, (can we mention) any pupil, either amongst strangers or citizens or any one else, either a free man or a slave, who assigns as the cause of his having become wise and good his intercourse with them? This too is not told. But they did not surely grudge to share their virtue with other persons. Perhaps so. Was it that there might not be rival artists, just as cooks, and physicians, and carpenters feel a jealousy; since it is not to their advantage for many rival artists to exist, nor for them to dwell amongst many similar persons. Is it then in like manner not an advantage for good men to dwell amongst many similar persons? Perhaps so. Are not the good and the just the same? Yes, they are. Is there the individual, to whom it is an advantage to live not amongst good persons, but amongst bad? I cannot tell. Can you not tell

this too, whether it is the work of good men to do a hurt, and of bad men to do a benefit, or the reverse'? The reverse. The good then do a benefit, the bad do a hurt. Yes. Is there a person who wishes to be hurt rather than to be benefited? By no means. No one therefore wishes to live amongst bad persons, rather than amongst good. It is so. Not one then of the good is so jealous of another, as (not) to make him a good person and similar to himself. From this reasoning it seems so. You have heard that Cleophantus was the son of Themistocles. I have heard it. It is evident then that Themistocles was not jealous of his son becoming the best possible; who (was jealous of) no one else, if indeed he was a good man; and (good) they say he was. Yes. You know then that Themistocles caused his son to be taught to be a clever and a good horseman. For instance he used to remain standing upright in the Meno, where Sydenham was the first to remark that this Thucydides was not the historian, but a political opponent of Pericles.

upon horses, and upright too hurled a javelin from (the backs of) the horses, and did many other wonderful feats, and taught him, and made him wise in many other things, such as are closely connected with a good education. Or have you not heard from elderly persons? I have heard it. No one then could find fault with the son's nature as being bad. Not justly so at least from what you have said. But what is this? that Cleophantus, the son of Themistocles, became; a good and wise man in the matters where his father was wise, have you ever heard from any younger or older person? I have not heard it. Do we then conceive that he wished to instruct his own son in these matters; but in the wisdom, in which he was wise himself, not to make him better than any of his neighbours, if virtue were a thing to be taught? It is not likely at least. Of such a kind then is this your teacher of virtue, to whom you have alluded? Let us then look to another, by name Aristides, who brought up Lysimachus, and instructed him the best of the Athenians on

such subjects as are connected with (good) teachers; and yet he made him a man no better than any body; for both you and I have seen and associated with him. It is true. You know too that Pericles brought up well his sons Paralus and Xanthippus, of the latter of whom you seem to me to have been the lover. These, as you know yourself, he taught to be horsemen inferior to none of the Athenians; and he instructed them to be inferior to no one in the rest of contests, and all the other things that are learnt by art. But did he not wish to make them good men? But perhaps, Socrates, they would have become so, had they not died young. You reasonably come to the aid of your beloved. But Pericles would have much rather made them clever in his own wisdom, than in music and contests, had virtue been a thing to be taught, and had he been able to make them good men. But (I fear) that it is a thing not to be taught; since Thucydides brought up well his two sons, Melesias and Stephanus, in behalf of whom you will not have it in your power to say, what you have done in behalf of the sons of Pericles; for one of these you surely know lived to old age, and the other much beyond. And yet their father taught them well other pursuits, and they wrestled the best of the Athenians. For he put one under Xanthias, and the other under Eudorus; and these were surely thought to wrestle the best of those of that period. Yes, they were. Is it not evident then, that he would not have taught his sons these things, where it was requisite to instruct them at an expense to himself, but those where without expending any thing it was requisite to make them good men. Now would he not have taught them this, if it were to be taught? It is likely at least. But perhaps Thucydides was a man of small means, and had not very many friends amongst the Athenians or their allies; and he was of a great family, and of great power in the state, and amongst the rest of the Greeks, so that if this had been a thing to be taught, he would have discovered a person amongst those of the country, or

foreigners, who would have made his son a good man, if he himself had, through his attention to state affairs, no leisure. But (I fear) that virtue is a thing not to be taught. Perhaps not. But if it is not to be taught, are the good naturally so from their birth? But this perhaps we shall discover by considering the matter in this way. Come then, (say,) do there exist the natures of good horses? They do exist. Are there not men, who possess an art, by which they know the natures of good horses, both as regards their body, with reference to running, and their feelings, which of them are full of spirit or devoid of it. Yes. What is this art, and what its name? Equestrian. Is there not in like manner an art relating to dogs, by which persons discriminate between the good and bad natures of dogs? There is. What is it? The hunter's art. There are too assayers amongst us of gold and silver, who, by looking, decide upon both the better and the worse (metal). There are. And what do you call them? Silver assayers. The boy-drillers moreover know, by examining the natures of the bodies of men, which of them are useful and which not, for each of their labours, and which of the bodies of persons older and young, are about to be worthy of note, and in which there is much hope of their executing works connected with the body. It is so. Whether then are good horses and dogs, and other things of such a kind, of more importance in states, or good men? Good men. Well then, do you conceive that, if the natures of men were good for virtue, that mankind would not have planned in every way to discover those natures? It is likely at least. Can you then mention any art, which has been exhibited and applied to the natures of good men, so as to enable persons to decide upon them? I cannot.' And yet the art would be worth much, and so too the parties possessing it. For they would have pointed out the young men, who, when they were still boys, were about to be good; and whom we should have taken and kept in the Acropolis for the public use, as if it were silver, and something more beautiful, in order that they

might not suffer any mischief, either in a fight or in any other danger, but be laid up as the saviours and benefactors of the state, since they should have arrived at a proper age. But it seems almost that virtue does not exist to mankind either by nature or instruction. How then, Socrates, would persons seem to become (good), if they do not become so by nature or instruction? By what other means could the good exist? This, I think, could not be shown easily; but I conjecture that the property (of goodness) is something especially divine, and that good men exist, as prophets do and oracle chaunters. For these exist neither by nature nor by art, but become such by the inspiration of the gods. And so too good men point out to states what is about on each occasion to happen, and what is about to be, from the inspiration of a god, much more, and more clearly, than oracle chaunters do: and even women somehow say that such a person is a divine man; and the Lacedaemonians too, when they praise in a very handsome manner, say that a man is divine, and often does Homer make use of the same expression, and the rest of poets likewise. When therefore a god wishes a state to do well, he causes some men in it to be good; but when a state is about to do ill, the god takes away the good men from it. Thus then it is likely that virtue is a thing not to be taught nor (derived) from nature, but exists by a divine allotment to those who possess it.

Definitions

OPOI

Plato

translated by George Burges

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Eternal — that which has existed formerly through all time, and is now not destroyed.

God — an immortal living-being, sufficient in itself for happiness; an eternal existence; the cause of the nature of the good.

Generation — a movement towards existence; a sharing through a change in existence; a progression towards existence.

The sun — a fire in heaven, which can alone be seen from morning to evening by the same; the greatest star, visible by day; a perpetually living being, possessing a soul. Time — a movement of the sun; a measure of progress.

Day — a journeying of the sun from its rising (east) to its setting (west); a light, the opposite to Night.

Morning — the beginning of day; the first light from the sun.

Mid-day — the time when the shadows of substances have the least length.

Evening — the close of day.

Night — darkness, the opposite to Day; a deprivation of the sun.

Chance — a proceeding from uncertainty to uncertainty, and from what is spontaneous; the cause of a fortuitous action.

Old Age — the wasting away of a thing with life, the result of time.

Wind — a movement in the air around the earth.

Air — an element, all of whose movements according to spabe are according to nature.

Heaven — a substance, surrounding all things perceived by the senses, except the uppermost air.

Soul — that which moves itself; the cause of vital motion in living beings.

Power — that, which is able by itself to produce an effect.

Vision — the (bodily) habit of distinguishing substances.

Bone — marrow, consolidated by heat.

Element — that, which combines and separates (particles) brought together.

Virtue — a (mental) constitution of the best kind; a habit of a mortal living being; the object of praise on account of itself; a habit, according to which that, which possesses it, is said to be good; a just communion of laws; a disposition, according to which that, which is constituted perfectly, is called steady; a habit, effective of a good state of law.

Discretion — a power effective by itself of the good fortune of man; a knowledge of things good and evil; a knowledge effective of felicity; a (mental) constitution, by which we determine what is to be done and what is not to be done.

Justice — an agreement of the soul with itself, and a correct arrangement of the parts of the soul towards each other and about each other; a habit, distributive to each person of that, which is according to worthiness; a habit, according to which he, who possesses it, can select what seems to him to be just; a habit in life, subservient to law; an equality that can share in common; a habit ministering to upright laws.

Temperance — a moderation of soul relating to the desires and pleasures, which exist in it according to nature; a fitness in, and correct ordering of, the soul, as regards its natural pleasures and pains; a harmony in the soul touching the states of ruling and being ruled; a self-acting according to nature; í [a well-ordering of the soul;] an intercourse of the soul, founded on reason, relating to things honourable and base; a habit

according to which he, who has it, can select and be cautious of what he ought.

Fortitude — a habit of the soul, not to be moved by fear; a boldness in war; a knowledge of the things relating to war; a command over the soul relating to things of fear and dread; a boldness subservient to discretion; a bold bearing under the expectation of death; a habit, preservative of right reasoning in dangers; a strength (of mind) balancing (the apprehension) of danger;”a strength, bearing up on the side of virtue; a tranquillity of soul with reference to things that appear, according to correct reasoning, to be full of dread and daring; the safe preservation of uncertain determinations relating to things of dread; a skill in war; a habit, that can abide in law.

Continence-a power enduring pain; a following of correct reasoning; a power not exceeded by that which is perceived by correct reasoning.

Self-sufficiency — a completion in the possession of good things; a habit, according to which they, who possess it, are the masters of themselves.

Reasonableness — a reduction in what is just and useful; a moderation in compacts; a well-ordering of the soul, founded on reason, as regards things honourable and base.

Endurance — the bearing-up against pain, for the sake of what is honourable; a bearing-up under labour for the sake of what is honourable.

Boldness — the non-expectation of an ill; an imperturbability in the presence of an ill.

Non-perception of pain — a habit, according to which we do not fall into sorrows.

The love of labour — a habit, that accomplishes what a person chooses (to do); a voluntary endurance; a habit not to be

cavilled at on the subject of labour.

Modesty — a voluntary shrinking from daring on just grounds towards what seems to be the best; a voluntary laying hold of the best; a cautious care of blame on just grounds.

Freedom — the ruling power of life; a power ruling by itself on every occasion; a power over that, which relates to oneself in life; an unsparingness in the use and possession of property.

Liberality — a habit in transacting money matters in a way that is fitting; the adding to, and possession of, property, as is meet.

Mildness — the settling down of an excitement arising from passion; a moderated temperament of soul.

Decorum — a voluntary yielding to what appears the best; a well-ordering respecting the movement of the body.

Felicity — a good composed of all good things; a power self-sufficient towards living well; a consummation as regards virtue; an utility self-sufficient for a living being.

Magnificence — the estimation according to correct reason of that which is the most worthy of respect.

Sagacity — a natural ability in the soul, according to which he, who possesses it, makes a conjecture in the quickest (time) relating to what needful; an acuteness of intellect.

Honesty — a simplicity in moral conduct in union with fair speaking; a steadiness in moral conduct.

Kalokagathia — a habit of selecting things that are the best.

High-mindedness — a gentlemanly use of accidental circumstances; a majesty of soul in union with reason.

Philanthropy — a habit of moral conduct that easily leads to a friendship with man; a habit of acting kindly towards men; the having thanks; a recollection with kind conduct.

Piety — -justice relating to the gods; a power paying attention to the gods willingly; a correct perception of the honour due to the gods; a knowledge of the honour due to the gods.

Good — that on account of itself.

Fearlessness — a habit, according to which we do not fall into fear.

Apathy — a habit, according to which we do not fall into sufferings.

Peace — a quietness as regards enmity in war.

Listlessness — an easiness of soul; apathy respecting the objects of anger.

Skilfulness — a habit, according to which he, who possesses it, is able to form a conjecture about the peculiar termination (of a thing).

Friendship — a union of sentiment, relating to things honourable and just; the choice of the same kind of life; a union in opinion on questions of sect and practice; a union in sentiment relating to a communion in life in combination with kind feelings; a communion in doing well and in suffering.

Nobility of birth — the virtue of a noble moral conduct; an easy leading of the soul to words and deeds.

Selection — a correct approval after examination.

Kind feeling — the selection of a person for the purpose of embracing by a person.

Familiarity — a sharing in the same family.

Agreement — a sharing in all things existing; a concordance in thoughts and conceptions.

Lovingness — a perfect exhibition. · Statesmanship — the knowledge of what is honourable and advantageous (for a

state); a knowledge productive of justice in a state.

‘ Sociality — a friendship arising from an association amongst persons of the same age.

Good counsel — the cognate virtue of reasoning. Belief — the correct conception of a thing being really as it seems to be; a firmness in moral conduct.

Truth — a. habit in affirming and denying; a knowledge of things true.

A wishing — a desire with right reason; a reasonable longing; a longing with reason, according to nature.

Counselling — an exhortation to another person, previous to acting, as to what manner it is meet to act.

Fit opportunity — the meeting with the time in which it is requisite to suffer or do something.

Caution — a guard against ill; the care of guarding (oneself).

Order — the working out a similarity in all things existing with a relation to each other; a symmetry of communion; the cause of all things existing with a relation to each other; a symmetry towards learning.

Application — a bracing up of the soul for learning.

Natural ability — a quickness in learning; a good production of nature; an excellence from nature.

Docility — a natural ability in the soul towards a quickness in learning.

Judgment — a peremptory decision respecting a disputed matter.

Law — the (process of a) contest respecting the having done an injury or not. .

Good legal conduct — an obedience shown to proper laws.

Cheerfulness — a. delight at the acts of a temperate person.

Honour — a gift of good things presented on actions done through virtue; a mark of esteem in return for virtue; the outward bearing of what is an object of reverence; the watching of a mark of esteem.

Alacrity — the exhibition of a practical preference.

Favour — a voluntary act of kindness; the return for a good act; a ministering at a fit time.

Concord — a similarity of opinion between rulers and ruled, how they ought to rule and be ruled.

A polity — the community of a multitude of persons, self-sufficient for a happy state; the community of a multitude according to law.

Forethought — a preparation with respect to things about to be.

Counsel — a consideration respecting future things how they may be advantageous.

Victory — a power having the superiority, as regards contention.

A ready-way-finding — a ready discrimination, that possesses a power over what is thought upon.

Bribe — the exchange for a favour.

Opportunity — the point of time suited to what is advantageous; a time that works for some good.

Memory — a disposition of the soul preservative of the truth that is in it.

The keeping in mind — the having thought on the stretch.

Thinking — the commencement of knowledge.

Holiness — a religious dread of sins against the gods; an attention to the honour due naturally to a deity.

A prophecy — a knowledge, that points out beforehand an action, without a demonstrative proof.

The prophetic art — a science, that speculates upon what is now and will be to a mortal being.

Wisdom — a science not-hypothetical; a knowledge of things as they happen to exist; a science that speculates upon the cause of things existing.

Philosophy — a longing after the knowledge of things as they happen to exist; a habit of speculating upon the truth as to how it is true; a careful study in combination with correct reasoning.

Knowledge — a comprehension by the soul, not to be changed or cast down by reasoning; [the power of comprehending a thing or things, not to be changed or thrown down by reasoning;] a true reasoning not to be changed or cast down upon reflection. .

Opinion — a conception to be changed by the persuasion of reason; a rational impetus; a notion falling upon false- “ hood and truth by (not-)reason.

Sensation — an impetus of the soul; a movement of mind; a heralding of the soul through the body to the seasons of man; from which there results a power of the soul devoid of reason, having a cognizance through the body.

Habit — a disposition of the soul, according to which we are said to be with certain qualities.

Voice — a flowing through the mouth from a thought.

Speech — voice expressed by letters descriptive of each of things existing; a form of language, compounded of nouns and verbs, without melody.

Noun — a form of language uncompounded, the interpreter of that which is predicated against being, and of every thing which is not spoken of against itself.

Language — the voice of a man, expressed by letters, and some common symbol, acting as an interpreter, without melody.

Syllable — an articulation of the human voice, expressed by letters.

Definition — a. sentence composed of difference and genus.

Proof — the showing forth of a thing not evident.

Demonstration — true reasoning 'founded on syllogisms; a reasoning, that makes a matter plain by what is previously known.

Element (of voice) — a vocal sound uncompounded; the cause to the rest of vocal sounds of their being vocal sounds.

Useful — the cause of doing well; the cause of good.

Advantageous — that which conduces to good.

Honourable — that which is good.

Good — the cause of safety to things existing; the cause of all that relates to itself; from which it happens to choose' what is meet.

Temperate — the orderly conduct of the soul.

Just — an ordonnance of law, productive of justice.

Voluntary — that which is drawn on by itself; that which is selected with reference to itself, (and) completed according to design.

Free — that which rules itself.

Moderate — a mean between excess and deficiency; and sufficient according to art.

Moderation — a mean between excess and deficiency.

Prize — the reward of excellence, that is chosen for its own sake.

Immortality — an existence endowed with soul and a remaining for ever.

A holy thing — service paid to a god, acceptable to a god.

Festival — a holy time according to law.

Man — an animal, wingless, biped, with wide nails; the only one of beings that is a recipient of knowledge founded on reason.

Sacrifice — the gift of a victim to a god.

Prayer — an asking for good things, or that seem so, by man from gods.

King — a ruler according to laws; not subject to the auditing of his accounts; the chief magistrate in a political constitution.

Government — the care of the whole.

Licence — a superintendence of law.

Law-giver — a maker of laws according to which it is meet for a polity to exist.

Law — a decree, relating to the state, made by the multitude, not limited to any time.

Hypothesis — a principle not demonstrated; the summary of a discourse.

A vote — a decree of the state limited to a certain time.

Statesman — a person skilled in the constitution of a state.

A state — the residence of a multitude of persons making use of decrees in common; a multitude of persons existing under the same law.

The excellence of a state — a constitution of a correct polity.

The science of war — skill in war.

Alliance — a communion in war.

Safety — a protection from injury.

Tyrant — Vi person ruling a state according to his own notion.

Sophist — a mercenary hunter after the young, rich, (and) in high repute.

Wealth — a possession suited for happiness; an abundance of means tending to happiness.

Deposit — a thing given with faith.

Purgation — a separation of the worse from the better.

To conquer — to possess the power, when having a difference.

A good man — such a one as is able to effect good for a person.

A temperate man — one who has moderate desires.

A continent man — one who has a power over the portions of the soul contending against right reason.

A steady man — one who is perfectly good; one who preserves his virtue.

Conscience — a reflection with pain without reason.

Indocility — a slowness in learning.

Lordship — a just government, not subject to the auditing of accounts.

Dislike of wisdom — a habit, according to which he, who has it, dislikes reasoning.

Fear — a consternation of the soul on the expectation of ill.

Passion — a violent impetus without reason; mind of regulation of soul without reason.

Consternation — a fear on the expectation of ill.

Flattery — a conversation to gratify 'without the best;' a habit of conversing to gratify, exceeding moderation.

Anger — an exhortation by passion to revenge.

Insult — an injury leading to dishonour.

Intemperance — 'A habit forcing a person, contrary to right reason, towards what seem to be pleasant.

Hesitation — a flight from the commencement of labours.

Cowardice — that which lays hold of (and detains) a rushing on; the cause of a (mental) contraction.

(A beginning) — the first cause of existence.

Calumny — the setting friends apart by a word.

Opportunity — that in which it is fitting to do and suffer each thing.

Injustice — a habit disregarding of laws.

Want — a diminution of good things.

Shame — a fear on the expectation of dishonour.

Vain-gloriousness — a habit of laying claim to a good or good things, not belonging to a person.

Sinning — acting contrary to right reason.

Envy — a pain at the good things of friends, which either are or have been.

Shamelessness — a habit of the soul, that endures dishonour for the sake of gain.

Rashness — the excess of boldness in the case of dangers, which it ought not.

A love of honour — a habit of the soul, lavish of every expense without consideration.

Natural depravity — a badness by nature, and a sinning in that, which is according to nature; a disease of that, which is according to nature.

Hope — the expectation of a good.

Madness — a habit destructive of a correct perception.

Talkativeness — intemperance in speech, devoid of reason.

Contrariety — the greatest standing apart of things, that according to a certain difference fall under the same genus.

Involuntary — that which is brought to an end contrary to intention.

Instruction — a power that has the cure of the soul.

Instructing — the delivering of instruction.

Legislation — the science that renders a state firmly fixed (and without suffering.)

Admonition — a speech that finds fault from design; a speech for the sake of turning aside from error.

Assistance — the hindering an ill either existing or in the way of existing.

Punishment — a curing of the soul for an error committed.

Power — a superiority in doing or speaking; a habit according to which that, which possesses it, is powerful; a strength according to nature.

To preserve — to protect from hurt.

(Science — is a knowledge without stumbling.)